

THE CRYOPOD TO HELL

The Cryopod to Hell (Classic)

by Klokinator

Parts 001-490

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Part 001:

"Just one last signature to confirm, Jason." Rebecca, one of the scientists in the room, smiles at me and tugs on her long, curly black hair.

She hands me a clipboard with a legal form clamped onto it. I barely glance at the paper before writing my name down. My body feels a little numb; it's hard to believe I'm finally committing.

"You'll be awake in less than the snap of a finger!" She smiles cheerfully, then steps back and presses a button on the side of my cryopod. A hatch closes in front of me, and a large glass window slides down, barring me from the outside world. It's my last chance to quit, back out, and leave... but I won't. I'm not going anywhere.

I stare out the transparent plexiglass around me as the pod closes. Nine other pods are here; their lids clamp down simultaneously. Each of their occupants' faces has a range of emotions, from nervousness, to fear, to even a bit of curiosity. The general atmosphere is intense, as this is only the third clinical trial the doctors have performed.

I feel different, compared to the others. A calmness overtakes me, making me feel as if I'm about to land softly in a field of butterflies. My eyes lazily take in the scene around me. When I next wake up, it will be a hundred thousand years in the future. Humanity won't look anything like they do now. They'll probably all be transformed into sci-fi robots, or they'll live in a massive virtual reality simulation, spinning around the sun in a Dyson sphere.

Gas hisses into the small enclosed space around me. First I'll be put to sleep, then I'll be frozen, and later the auto-warmup routine will run, waking me up. This machine is supposed to have enough power attached to its battery that it won't run out before the designated time, and it will still wake me up if the battery runs low early.

If it fails... I don't even care. Maybe I'll die, frozen like an icicle. My eyes suddenly felt a need to shut. I'm so sleepy... it's time to have no regrets...

* * *

An instant passes.

OH SHIT! I'M AWAKE, my thoughts scream in my mind, like a drunken man in a bar. I jerk up, bashing my face on the plexiglass. Didn't the gas knock me out? I was so calm a second ago, but now I'm a bucket of nerves. My hands are shaking, what the fuck just happened? The glass

is fogged up already. My body is stiff; did I even go to sleep? Goddamn, Rebecca wasn't joking. That was insanely fast. I don't remember dreaming. Or maybe I'm still asleep?

I pinch my thigh, noticing my grip is almost nonexistent. I'm weaker than a wet piece of paper,

but my sense of touch is present, even though most of my body is numb. Small victories, Jason.

Small victories.

Another hissing sound. Is that more sleeping gas? No wait, the hatch is opening. I can't see anything, the glass is still fogged up, and there's no room for my hands to move so I can wipe the fog away. Might as well just wait.

The hatch starts moving slowly. Very slowly. It must be crawling at a fraction of an inch per minute. Why is it so sluggish? By the time it's moved several inches, I'm about ready to kill myself out of boredom. The room is pitch black, aside from the blue light of my pod. I can only see past the cracks of the hatch as it lifts up, but there's no mistake, the room is shrouded in dense darkness.

A shiver goes down my spine as the glass slowly inches away from my face. I can't see more than a foot forward, not even to the floor. The light is very dim, and it seems to be getting fainter. Is the battery failing? Not good. It better have enough juice to at least release me.

Luckily it does. After the door stops moving raises fully, the light brightens dramatically. It must have dimmed since the light and door share the same power source.

The problem is what I see next. My skin crawls at the sight. There are no other pods here. The shiny metallic floor that I remember, the towering roof, all of it is gone. I'm not in the same location anymore. Hell, maybe I am and a hundred thousand years has done a number on the place.

No, that can't be the case, my mind warns me. I cautiously stagger forward, using the door frame to prop my body up. I reach my first bare foot out, and as it touches the floor, I feel a curious sensation. My foot is still very numb, but there's no mistaking it, the ground is warm. And it's smooth. The land is earthen, but it isn't a layer of dirt covering the floor of the Cryotek facility.

I take in the room around me. Everything including the walls, floor, ceiling, and four mysterious pillars in the middle of the room are made of dirt, and just as smooth as the floor. The walls are much closer than I remember. The entrance to the room is on the opposite side

from what I remember as well. Perhaps my pod was moved. What are the pillars? They don't seem to reach the ceiling; they stand only ten feet tall or so.

Wait, are those markings? I stumble toward the pillars and fall on the floor. My knees groan in pain, but I crawl closer to the four columns since I can't stand properly without support, and the floor is so smooth that I can drag myself across it effortlessly anyway.

There are markings, repeated, endlessly, all over each pillar. They appear to be Japanese.

Perhaps Chinese, but I'm no linguist, and moonspeak all looks the same to me.

死が来ます

死が来ます

死が来ます

The markings cover every possible edge and nook and cranny, but I have no idea what they mean. They give me the creeps, so I decide not to dwell on their significance.

The door, right, I need to get out of this room. The cryo-preserved storage cases the scientists left me with aren't here, and I'm weak with hunger. God, what if I'm not even in the future? What if I've woken up ten days later and this is all some elaborate prank? The researchers could have set up all kinds of crazy experiments, and I wouldn't know. I should have read the small print!

The thought this is all a prank is comforting but unlikely, given what I know about CryoTek. I don't think this is a prank... an accident must have happened.

I finally reach the door. It's massive, standing nearly the full height of the wall. It appears to be a double door, with the center being what I must push on to open it. Curiously though, even though I'm now many feet from the pod and the light is dim, I again see more repeating characters covering the entirety of the door. These look different though.

決して離れません

決して離れません

決して離れません

What do they mean? No matter. I'll find the answers later.

I push with all my might, and hear a hissing sound as the door slowly opens. It's almost like when Indiana Jones opens the sarcophagus, and the oxygen is sucked in. Suddenly, I feel strength returning to my body, and realize I had been taking shallow breaths until just now. The room was nearly devoid of fresh air, so I'm lucky I didn't pass out and die.

With a new surge of energy, I heave the door open.

Part 002:

I don't know what I expected.

The door opens, and I see nothing. There's a room somewhere in the darkness, but my eyes are useless at piercing the veil of shadow. Maybe if I could cast magic missile, that would change. Why can't humanity of the year One Hundred Thousand pay the goddamn electric bill, or whatever? They probably use cosmic space energy or something.

A *humming* noise fills the room around me. My bones rattle under my skin, though the sensation is faint and indistinct. It's everywhere, yet nowhere. The humming is as if the air itself is quivering in fear.

Oh, damn, maybe being frozen for a hundred thousand years made me evolve ESP or something. That would be awesome, but unlikely. My hopes are dashed against the rocks. *Let's be realistic about this, and consider what I know.*

The floor is comfortably warm, like sitting a few feet away from a fire, while also covered in smooth dirt. Weird moonspeak is etched into the doors and those pillars. The air itself is trembling in fear. Everyone I've ever known and loved is probably dead.

I'm at least somewhat sure that I'm not in the original CryoTek lab where I started out, and I may have evolved a functional spider-sense.

Yeah, this isn't helping. The year 100,000 A.D. makes no sense at all.

I wander back over to the pod. What once required a small feat of endurance is now just a few light steps away. It's amazing how my life can change so quickly!

Examining the pod, I find a small hatch on its rear. When I pop it out, a little compartment appears, with some items inside.

There's a ten-foot nylon rope, a badly rusted handgun of some sort, a knife that's corroded and flaking apart, and what I assume is a flashlight. Also a few cans of... *food*? The cans aren't labeled, and while food preservation might be a fine art, I'm terrified of what the contents will reveal. Let's skip the chow for right now.

I pull the stuff out of the compartment and find a small knapsack made from nylon at the bottom, with straps for wearing it like a backpack.

Well, that's handy. At least I have some... tools. I don't think a rusted dull knife will be much use, the flashlight might not work, the gun is toast, and god only knows what Lucifer himself put in the cans of food, but at least I have supplies, meager though they be.

I stick everything into the knapsack and click the flashlight. Nothing happens. *Great, that's just wonderful.* I figured this was a waste of time! But wait, there's some kind of... crank? Oh, that's right, this looks like one of those flashlights from the as-seen-on-TV ads, where you can crank the bottom to power it. *Surely it won't work, right?*

It does. Hallelujah, I'm saved! I crank it with all my strength and get a dim light that shines forward ten or so feet. The illumination is weak at best, but at least I won't be falling into any bottomless chasms or spike pits now that I have a light source.

Walking towards the still-open door, I crank the flashlight and light up the next room.

A statue. In the middle of the floor, there's a goddamn terrifying statue there. My knees shake, and teeth chatter as I walk toward it. If I had to describe the thing, I'd call it a- well, a monster, I suppose. I don't see any other way to describe it.

Long beak, with hundreds of tiny teeth creeping out the sides. Three 'arms,' with the third protruding from its chest. Each arm has several razor-sharp talons. The creature's eyes are small and beady, and they appear to follow me as I move around the room, while the tall and imposing body (easily *twice* my height) dwarfs me with its intimidating presence. A spiny, curved tail sticks out behind it, with a mace-like club attached to the end. In the ancient times, didn't a few types of dinosaurs have clubs on the end of their tails? That's what this statue resembles.

My eyes pan over the freak abomination's body, and as I look down towards its feet, something catches my eye. The floor. The floor is covered in that goddamn writing again.

プロテクター

プロテクター

プロテクター

But that's not all. The walls are also covered in writing, but the symbols are different from the ones on the floor.

デストロイヤー

デストロイヤー

デストロイヤー

What do they mean? If I'd known reading Japanese would have been necessary at any point in my life, I'd have tried learning it from my father before he passed away. Curse my lack of foresight!

But more importantly, what's up with this freak? Why is it facing my door, like a warning or a threat to me when I exit it? I swear, if this is some elaborate ruse to screw with me, I'm going to murder whoever did it. I'd also rather it be a prank at this point because this unease is making my life expectancy drop by several years.

Part 003:

Carefully, I shimmy my way past the statue. On the opposite side of the room is yet another door, though this one blends into the wall seamlessly. Its surface is bare, without any writing like the first one I stepped through.

A thought occurs to me as I start to push it open. *How am I breathing oxygen?* Pulling away, I glance upward, above the statue. A small, square hole, barely big enough for a cat to fit through, catches my eye. I shine my flashlight up at it and sigh, realizing there's no point trying to climb up inside of it. Not only wouldn't I fit, but I'd also have to climb on top of the statue to reach, and *no way* is that happening, no sir.

Turning my attention back to the door, I start shoving it with all my might, but I'm surprised when the massive slab of stone easily flings open as if it were gliding on ice. I trip and fall forward, slamming on the ground and dropping my flashlight. In a panic, I grab my only source of light and shine it back at the statue, but the thing is in the same place as it was before. Damn my irrational paranoia.

Cautiously, I pull myself to my feet and aim the light into the new room. Well, it isn't actually a room, it's a hallway. The walls expand outward, widening dramatically to almost three times the width of the chamber I'm in now, and the ceiling is so high that the flashlight's beam can't reach it.

Slowing my breath to abnormal levels, I mutter to nobody in particular, "No need to be afraid. There's nothing here but your nerves, Jason," and slowly I tiptoe out into the corridor, glancing around nervously as I patter forward.

Darkness stretches out all around me. I can just barely see the walls on each side, and cranking the light doesn't give it much more juice. "H-hello?" My words are but a whisper, and the ether sucks them from my lips, absorbing them into the faint humming of the background noise that permeates this place.

No response greets me, as I walk further into the darkness. All at once, I feel a faint breeze on my back, and my body stiffens. Before I can spin around, a thunderous *BOOM* from behind nearly makes me piss myself in terror.

The door from the Cryopod room. *It just closed.*

Oh my god, oh my god...

It's no big deal! The door must have had a spring on it or something!

My mind screams irrationally at me at me as I slowly turn around and shine my flashlight at the source of the noise.

What I see next chills me to my very core.

The statue. *It's gone.*

Part 004:

For a moment, I lose the ability to control my body. My legs give out, and I fall to the floor as I stare at the spot where that goddamned statue was just standing. I don't feel like a human right now, as my eyes leap from one crevice of the room anywhere else. My mind invents a thousand possibilities for where the statue went, even thinking of crazy shit, like *maybe it's just invisible to the human eye suddenly, haha!*

No matter where I look, one thing is certain: the room that once held the statue is now empty.

It's hard to think rationally. My hands shake as I carefully pull myself off the ground. I take a few steps back, as one very obvious thought crosses my mind. *What if that wasn't a statue after all?*

Everything about this creepy, dark dungeon makes my skin crawl. If someone is trying to pull a practical joke on me, it isn't funny.

Jesus Christ! What if the statue monster is sitting behind the door, waiting for me to turn my back so it can pounce at me and devour my insides?! I'm actually thinking of opening the door for some dumb reason *but that would be suicidal haha why would anyone do that?!*

Quickly, and stealthily, I rush over to the door, push it shut as quietly as possible, then break into a dead run in the opposite direction, making sure to only run on my tiptoes. *You bet your sweet ass I don't want that thing to hear me!* Please tell me the freakazoid isn't hungry. *Please!*

Even as I run for minutes, putting distance between me and where I came from, my breath starts to come in ragged gasps and I have to slow to a stop, doubling over and wheezing as sweat pours off my brow. I was never a particularly athletic young man in school, and I sat around playing video games and Chess to pass the time before my appointment with Cryotek came up. I'm surprised I managed to run for as long as I just did.

To make matter worse, I have no food or water. If the abomination doesn't eat me, I'll die of hunger and dehydration. I need to catch a break!

As I plop down on the ground, finally deciding to catch my breath, my heart slams against my chest. I hear something, something from very far behind me in the direction I came from.

Footsteps. Distinct, loud, and very very slow.

Thud. 1, 2, 3... Thud... 1, 2, 3... thud.

Oh god. *It's coming.*

Part 005:

My eyes nearly pop out of my skull, and my knees rattle in terror as I stare into the darkness behind me. The monster is in the distance, and it's coming this way. I'm going to die. I can hear the bells tolling in the back of my mind.

This is no time to rest, you lazy sack of shit, get your ass up and MOVE, my conscience and inner ego scream at me. My body creaks but I somehow manage to leap to my feet thanks to a surge of adrenaline.

I don't have the strength to run, but if that thing is coming as slowly as it sounds like it is, a power-walk will hopefully keep me ahead of it.

Ahead of it? The realization that a monster is coming to eat me makes me quicken my pace. What is going on? What kind of purgatory am I in? Did I die? Am I in Hell? Yeah Lucifer, you're hilarious, you goddamn piece of garbage! Just throw everything you've got at me all at once!

I do my best to walk-jog and stay ahead of the plodding footsteps behind me, but I pause for a moment and listen intently. Something is off about their tempo.

Thud... 1, 2, Thud... 1, 2, Thud.

The monster is quickening its pace. It's speeding up, and I'm still thoroughly exhausted. At this rate, I'm going to die from my heart imploding before the damn thing can catch me. What if the statue monster is toying with me? Maybe it's like a bird teaching its babies to feed.

Hold on... babies? Haha, that's- *NO!* What about the hole in the ceiling? That can't be- nope, I must purge the thought.

Just as I turn around and start jogging, a new sight greets my eyes. The opposite wall. I've finally reached it.

A colossal double-door looms before me, stretching all the way up to the ceiling. I can't see the top of it with my flashlight, but one thing is for sure: it's much too big for me to open. I'm trapped.

Wait, no! On both sides of it, to the left and right, much smaller doors sit. Each one is about the same size as the stone slabs from before, and once again those goddamn markings are spread across each one.

On the left door:

餌食

餌食

餌食

And on the right:

安全性

安全性

安全性

If only I had learned Japanese! I never thought it was going to be useful in my life, so I squandered my studies.

The footsteps that once sounded distant are growing steadily closer. Not much longer and that fucking dinosaur reject is going to emerge from the darkness and tear me to ribbons. Which way do I go?!

My gut tells me 'left is right,' so without any reason whatsoever, I charge into it, shoving with all my might until it groans open. Quickly, I slam the door behind me and lean against it, breathing like my lungs are on fire. Before me is a narrow hallway that curves slightly to the side. Wherever this leads, I have to follow it.

I'm *not* going back out there.

As I rush down the hallway, one thought enters my mind. *Life has a way of ruining my plans.*

Part 006:

The adrenaline rush as my body trembles in terror eventually winds down, once I realize the footsteps are no longer audible behind me. Slowing to a tentative walk, I stare ahead into the corridor, always shining my flashlight forward, aside from when I check behind myself for jump-scares.

The first thing I begin to realize is that I'm very subtly descending downward. Indeed, conventional logic would imply that to escape this place, I must head upward, to the outside sky, but I don't have much of a choice in the matter. In fact, not only is the floor gently sloping down, but it's also curving to the left, though I wasn't sure at first as the change was somewhat gradual.

After I gather my bearings, I continue walking down the sloping corridor, wondering all the while if I will ever see anything besides these dark, earthen walls. I pause eventually, as I notice that the humming sound has grown more noticeable, but I still don't hear the monster following me.

My flashlight sputters slightly, and I sigh as I reach for the crank. Just as it goes out, I pause, noticing a faint light up ahead. Squinting, I take a few steps forward and confirm that yes, in fact, there is a light somewhere at the end of this damned corridor. This realization fills me with hope, as well as dread. One does not merely create light in a place like this without belonging to some ancient horror.

Despite the lack of light around me, I press on, creeping forward slowly. My flashlight would probably reveal my presence if there's *something* up ahead. I'd prefer not to expose myself to a different monster, even as I escape the first.

The light grows brighter as I carefully tiptoe down the hallway, and soon it's bright enough that I can easily see all around myself. My body is coated in fluid from the cryo-chamber, but it's begun to dry and harden into millions of sticky white flakes. I'll be lucky if I ever feel clean again.

The room where the light is pouring from is just through the doorway up ahead. I lean around the corner and peek with one eye, and what I see takes my breath away.

Three colossal statues, standing at least a hundred feet tall, tower over everything else in the room. I almost cry when I realize they aren't chiseled into the likenesses of monsters, but into figures of human men.

Each statue is against a different wall, and all three of them are unique, holding different poses.

The first is a man with a long beard. A crown rests atop his head, and while the crown may be the same drab grey as the person it rests upon, bumps and dots line it, indicating it was a crown with many jewels studded inside. The man wears many layers of robes, each piled atop the other, and a long staff with a jewel is in his grasp, held proudly, as if he were going to cast a spell with it. To describe him, I would say he was a wise leader, someone who was fair and just. No evil escaped his gaze, but no righteousness went unrewarded either.

The next statue is of a man holding a mighty sword, both hands grasping its handle, the sword pointed out from his body, as if at any moment he could leap into action and cut his foes down. His expression is grim. He has seen many battles in his lifetime, and I can tell from the way the statue was carved that he was a feared warrior among his people. Some kings order their men from the rear flanks, while others lead the charge.

The final person is different. His arms hang limply at his sides, and his head is bowed, eyes closed. Tears, or perhaps drops of blood, roll down his cheeks. This man gave everything he had and fought to the end, but it wasn't enough. A closer glance reveals a necklace hanging from one of his hands, barely wrapped around one of his fingers. He died before his time was right, and now his likeness is frozen forever in memory of his final thoughts, *I wish I had done more*.

The statues aren't the only thing in the room. Gold coins are piled in the center of the room, mounds and heaps as far as I can see. If I weren't in a dark, festering hell, I might be tempted to call it the wealth of El Dorado. Amidst the gold, I spot weapons, armor, and even jewels.

But despite the incredible sights to behold, all of it pales in comparison to the final object that catches my gaze. The incredibly brilliant source of light that illuminates the entire room.

An orb rests atop a small, nondescript alter. A light not unlike that of the sun shines forth from it, reflecting off the gold and creating a dazzling display to draw my eyes to it.

The light isn't a static thing, like a lightbulb, but *alive*, coursing with energy. The humming that I've been feeling, without a doubt, emanates from it.

Slowly, I step toward it, my eyes darting around, looking for enemies and threats. None appear. As I approach, I spot, of all things, a wooden sign erected before the orb. That moonspeak is written on it as well, but this time, there is only one set of characters, written a single time.

パワ—

What do they mean? Are they a warning? A threat? Perhaps even an invitation?

As I stare at the orb, a sudden chill rushes down my back. Behind me, just around the bend I came from, a scratching sound, like a foot scuffing pavement, makes my breath catch in my throat.

Something *did* follow me.

Is this where I die?

Part 007:

I am not trembling in terror; I am not shaking in terror; I am *spasming* in terror. My bones click together violently as I hear the *thing* creeping around the bend behind me. *You're dead! It's going to eat you*, my mind screams in alarm. Tears pour down my face, but I dare not wipe them away. I don't have time.

Suddenly my shaking stops. An idea forms in my mind. Instinct takes over. *That orb. I need it. I must have it!*

I go from a shaking mess about to be devoured, to an animal fleeing to the only possible refuge, the one thing in this room that I know must mean *something*. As I rush toward the glowing orb of spirituality, a sudden scrambling noise behind me makes my skin crawl as the *thing* races around the corner after me. The last thing I hear before I grab the orb is a terrifying, unearthly scream, like that of a woman being torn apart by an abomination.

Serenity. Peace.

My hand rests on the orb, and the panic in my body melts away. *There's nothing to be afraid of now*, someone unknown says to me. Perhaps it's my mind playing tricks.

Calmly, I look back over my shoulder. The statue monster isn't there, but something else is. A shadow. I don't mean the sort of shadow made when something blocks the light, but a creature comprised entirely of blackness. I can barely even see it thanks to the brilliance of the orb and how it illuminates every corner of the room all at once, but it's there.

For a moment, it seems that the Shadow isn't moving, but after a few seconds of staring, I realize it is. Time has slowed to a crawl. It's as if I'm in the Matrix, and touching the orb has transformed me into an awakened Neo. I cock my head and stare at the creature for a moment, realizing that I'm not panicking, and yet I should be. My mind warns me that the monster is dangerous, but my body hasn't a care in the world. A sensation of power flows through my body, making me feel as if I could crush a rock with my mind.

How strange. Perhaps it isn't that time has slowed down, but that I have sped up. I'm no longer exhausted, and in fact, I could run a triathlon this very instant. Why am I so full of energy? Before, my breath was ragged and my legs scarcely even worked, but now, my body is as ready for action as if I had napped for a year straight.

After gazing at the Shadow for a moment, my eye catches the glint of something behind it. This may sound strange, but an object is glowing in the distance, and it isn't in my room.

Instead, I *will* my eyes pierce through the walls, spotting a sword in an entirely different room. In another direction, a crown glows, as if it's a beacon designed to draw my attention.

I begin to notice even more glowing objects. A set of chest armor, a shin-guard, a paladin's shield, and many other such things, all of them drawing my eyes like a moth to a flame.

When I lower my eyes to look below me, my happiness fades. Something roils in the deep, frightening and disturbing, and the longer I gaze at it, the more my newfound calmness transforms into abject horror.

A glowing sea of red, rapidly flowing from east to west, but inside the water is-

No. I don't- I can't believe it. This is too much! I don't want to be here anymore! I want to go back to the past!!

The river is filled with humans, or rather, the souls of humans. Bubbling up from the deep, millions, perhaps billions of faces rise and fall, screaming in pain and agony. They rise out of the hellish river, their skin begins to grow back, but they fall back in, only for that cycle to continuously repeat, over and over again. Their eternal suffering won't end, for they are cursed to wallow in misery, until the end of time.

This can't be the future. I must have died and gone to Hell.

Part 008:

Something is bothering me. That might sound asinine, given the literal river of souls under my feet, but the river isn't what I'm referring to. I'm being watched. Somewhere, in this hell, another presence gazes at me, evaluates me, and registers me as a threat. I can't pinpoint where this feeling of mine comes from, but it permeates every cell of my body. My stomach tightens as I flick my gaze around, trying to find the source of my anxiety.

Turning back to the Shadow, I narrow my eyes. Instinctively, I raise my palm up and spread my fingers out in a 'stop' gesture. The Shadow, unable to halt its snail-worthy momentum, continues to leap at me, but a single word escapes my lips. "**Light.**"

A ray of energy shoots out of my hand, enveloping the Shadow's entire side of the room in a luminous warmth, almost as bright as gazing at the sun during the heat of the midday. The shadow opens its mouth, but no sound comes out, as it melts away, devoured by the power of a single word.

Odd. Why did I do that? How and why did I know that I could shoot magical light rays out of my hand? Am I in some form of virtual reality? Of course not, that would be ludicrous! Besides, the floor beneath me still feels quite warm, and my sensation of touch can't be as easily fooled as my eyes and ears can.

But then, if I *were* in the future, especially a hundred thousand years or so, perhaps virtual reality has evolved? Who knows what a futuristic humanity could come up with. This might be well beyond anything a primitive like myself could even imagine.

Time returns to normal, and the orb dulls somewhat, no longer acting like a miniature sun in the palm of my hands. While it doesn't illuminate as much of the room, my eyes hurt much less, so it's an improvement compared to before.

In any case, I'm not going to figure out where I am or understand my predicament by randomly guessing. This orb has given me the ability to shoot holy rays of light, so it's a suitable weapon. I'm useless with a sword, and the armor laying around is way too big for me, so I doubt I'll need anything else. I'd better just get out of here.

Sloshing my way through the piles of gold, I almost trip a few times, but manage to keep myself together. I consider taking some of the gold with me, but I doubt it'll be any use. Hell, it'll probably just slow me down. I can probably come back later if I find a use for it.

After wading through the gold, I evaluate the three statues. To the right of each one, on all three walls opposite the door I entered from, there are passages leading to various other

hallways. Unlike every other instance up to this point, the moonspeak that lead me here isn't anywhere to be seen. I can go right, left, or forward, and there are no indicators which way is the correct path to take. Hell, with my luck, they're *all* the wrong path.

I don't know where the passages lead, but one thing is for certain: I do *not* want to head down. It may be miles and miles below, but that river of souls is the last place I want to be.

When I was fleeing the statue monster, I used the left door, and it paid off for me. Since the left passage seems to head back up, in the opposite direction as the river of souls, I trudge past the piles of coin and step inside the hallway, and am pleasantly surprised to see rocks embedded in the walls, every ten feet or so, that glow. While they don't illuminate much, they don't need to, either. That's what my new orb is for, after all!

With a pep in my step, I force the thoughts of the statue monster to the back of my mind and head down the passage, praying to whatever gods may still exist to watch over me.

* * *

As the puny human leaves the room, the Three Great Kings turn their heads to look at one another.

The Knowledge-Seeker: Is that boy a candidate?

The One Who Weeps: Difficult to say. I saw no rejection. Anything is possible.

The Greatest Sinner: He is part of the great cycle. In the direst times of need, a champion will rise. The time is right.

The One Who Weeps: It doesn't matter. The boy cannot redeem our failures. All hope is lost.

The Greatest Sinner: As long as one draws breath, there is always hope. You have forgotten the ancient struggles.

The Knowledge Seeker: You speak the truth, Arthur. As long as the boy has the Power of the Kings, he can right the wrongs we've wrought.

The One Who Weeps: He will break, just as we did, just as all heroes do. Man cannot overcome his weakness.

The Knowledge Seeker: Ye of little faith. That is why you fail.

Part 009:

The orb illuminates the hallway around me, though it probably wouldn't be very necessary given that the glowing rocks embedded in the wall are doing a fine job of that.

The hallway is surprisingly short, maybe a walk of two city blocks, when I arrive at a small, unimposing door. Naturally, the weird writing is covering the door again.

ホームベース

ホームベース

ホームベース

It could mean anything. Maybe it's another warning? Perhaps it's telling me to turn back? I don't know, but I feel the need to enter.

The door glides open without making a sound. The next sight I see is jarring.

Wood. The next room is made of wood, almost like I'm in a well built home from my own era. There's a... fireplace? With no fire going. There's a dining room table, chairs, a small quaint kitchen area, and other normal looking doors that presumably lead to rooms such as a bedroom and a bathroom.

Strange. That word keeps repeating in my head. Everything I keep finding only makes more questions appear. Nothing has answered any questions yet.

Despite the newfound strength I gained from the orb, my mind is fatigued, and I am hungry, so hungry. So thirsty. Walking to the kitchen area, I spy a sink. A plain old regular everyday sink. There's no way it works, right? I turn the nozzle, and... something comes out. It's certainly a liquid, but that is not... water. That is not the color of water, it's all... *green* and stuff.

At this point if it's poison, I'll take it just to end myself. Death might just be better than the agony of living in this psychopathic labyrinth. I dab my finger under the flow and hesitantly bring it to my lips. Stretching out my tongue, I lightly lick my finger slightly to get a taste of the green substance.

I process the taste and stare numbly at the liquid flowing out. You must be joking. This tastes like fucking Gatorade. Is this a joke? Someone is having a good laugh at my expense right now, I guarantee it. This is definitely Gatorade.

It's probably poisoned but fuck it, I'm thirsty. I cup my hands under it and bring many handfuls repeatedly to my mouth. It tastes not too sweet and not too salty. I have confirmed this

is definitely Gatorade and hopefully it's poisoned so I will be dying soon. It'd be great if it was a quick death.

After I shut off the faucet, I look to my right, and notice the wall has a faintly glowing... button? I probably shouldn't press that.

I press it. Nearby the button, the wall slides down to reveal a small illuminated hatch, roughly the size of a microwave. In it, cold air pours out. And inside it sits... you're kidding. The surprises never end.

I pull out the chilled food. This may be the year One Hundred Million, but at least we still have chicken.

Part 010:

The food was hearty and filling. It was also icy cold and hard at first, but apparently I can create fire out of my palm. Interesting, I'm a wizard now, apparently. If only my name was Harry.

After checking the other three doors in this room, I confirmed they all led to other perfectly normal rooms and the only way out of this labyrinthine hell would be to leave out the original door I came in from, so I first barricade it with the furniture in the dining room (Not necessarily to stop things from entering, but to make noise and give me warning while I sleep) and then I head back into the bedroom, which has a big beautiful bed there with elaborate quilted blankets and all sorts of strange designs on them, with creatures that resemble dragons and monsters from old fairy tales.

What I find curious though, is the decorations in all 4 rooms of this small house-like structure. The first room is decidedly "modern" based on the amenities it provides, reminding me of the things that existed in the year I left from, though the wooden walls remind me of a somewhat older building.

The bathroom however, resembles an old Japanese style toilet, where you squat over it to do your business.

The bedroom is Victorian in nature. Very old, with a big beautiful mirror made of oak and glass on the wall, and the big bed with its four tall wooden pillars that extend up towards the ceiling.

The last room though... it blows my mind. It's a small armory. It's packed to the brim with weapons, armor, all of it highly advanced, far beyond anything I've ever imagined. The problem? I can't figure out how to use any of it. Most of the things I see are clearly weapons, yet they have no triggers or anything that would imply they could fire projectiles. Maybe they read your brain to fire or something, but even stranger is that they're all very big and heavy, shaped in a way that is definitely not human-size.

And the armor is unwearable. It's not human sized, or shaped. As cool as all of this looks, it seems to be useless to me. Oh well, I can shoot fire and light out of my hands, what use do I have for weapons anyway?

I'm going to sleep now, tomorrow, I shall begin my exploration of the labyrinth in full.

Part 011:

I wake up quickly. I slept all "night" (If such a thing exists in this place) with the orb buried under several layers of mattress so that the light wouldn't keep me awake. Waking up, I notice the room is very dark, though the light is still so bright that it slightly gives the room a dull glow.

Pulling the orb out from under the covers slowly, I wince as the brightness flows into my eyes. But given a few minutes, my eyes adjust and I stare at it. The orb is definitely not a normal thing. Nothing here is, but this orb seems very special. It gives me abilities that are beyond human. It lets me see things I shouldn't be able to see. As long as it's in my possession I can do things no human should be able to do.

Looking at it more closely, I note that there seems to be little... *things* moving around inside the orb. Almost like little worms made of light, rapidly zipping around, back and forth.

As I stare at the orb, I get a feeling in my body, a strange buzzing feeling, like a gnat right beside my ear. I swat at it, but the feeling stays.

"...you?"

A voice seems to whisper in my ear.

"...are you?"

It's becoming more distinct.

"Who are you?" It suddenly clears up and speaks to me, right in my mind. It's telepathically communicating to me, but it almost feels like someone is whispering loudly in my ear.

"Me? I'm just... a time traveler, I guess." I figure maybe it's the orb speaking to me. Can't be that farfetched now, can it?

The orb however, grows silent, perhaps satisfied with my answer. It no longer speaks to me. Okay, well, I guess it just wanted to know who had the audacity to touch it, maybe?

Getting off the bed, I go back into the kitchen hub room and walk to the refrigerator-type utility in the wall. I had eaten all the chicken that was there and it probably has nothing left. Pressing the button, I'm stunned to see that there is more food in there, this time, an amazing looking delicious cake. It's chocolate, with black frosting covering the entire thing, and cherries on top, and in the center is a single candle.

As I reach for it, and pull it out, I'm dumbfounded to see that the moment I touch it and pull it out of the fridge, it becomes another chicken.

"The cake is a lie..." I whisper.

Eating the chicken after carefully cooking it, I head out the door, with my trusty orb in hand, and walk out to the main hallway and the room of El-Dorado's treasure hoard, as I have now coined it.

Walking around the room, I decide to head down another door that is directly across from the safe room I just left. Inside it, I notice many things immediately.

-We're back to a total lack of illumination, the hallway is completely dark.

-The floor is no longer smooth dirt, it's roughed up, and beaten up, with potholes here and there, clumps of dirt tossed here and there, the whole thing looks completely messy compared to the floors I've walked on since arriving here.

-The ceiling is still made of smooth dirt, as are the walls.

And as I walk down the hallway, I notice many doors on the right and then the left, and then the right again. 9 doors in total. They alternate, one on the right, one on the left, one on the right, and so on.

When I get to the end of the hallway, I spot another door, this one of a size comparable to most doors I've entered before. I decide not to go through it yet though, I want to see what's going on among these smaller side doors first.

Walking back to the entrance of this hallway, I hesitantly push on the first door.

It doesn't budge.

Odd, every door I've tried to enter so far has been little or no resistance. This door is firmly stuck on something. I pause to weigh the options. What if it's stuck on something I don't want to know about? What if there's a monster behind the door?

These don't really matter. If this place wanted me dead, it had many opportunities already. I shove the door, putting all my strength into it.

"Orb, if you have any power, now would be a great time to use it!"

My muscles suddenly surge as I put my all into it, and the door, pushing past whatever was obstructing it, suddenly flies open and I stumble into a small room and fall on the floor.

The floor is smooth.

Oh no.

There are four pillars.

Oh god.

There's writing on the pillars.

死が来ます

死が来ます

死が来ます

And at the back side of the room. There's a broken down cryopod, torn to pieces.

The walls are covered in blood.

Part 012:

The smell is sickening. How long has this room been here? I stifle my gag reflex and use all my willpower to force chunks of chicken back down my throat. I don't ever want to eat meat again after seeing this sight.

The smell of death is thick here, though definitely not fresh. The blood on the walls is hardened and crusty, and brown, like it has been here for an eon or two.

There is a corpse in the room, scattered here and there. Whoever it was, presumably the previous cryopod's occupant, they're unrecognizable, desiccated to a point where a DNA scientist would be hard pressed to identify the remains, and torn to pieces. I quickly bow my head and say a quick prayer before bowing out of the room and pulling the door shut behind me.

I'm much more hesitant to check the next room, but I still do it anyway. After the previous room, this one doesn't shock me. It's the same scene, blood everywhere, a corpse torn to pieces, a cryopod destroyed completely and scattered all over the room, pieces of skin and bone stuck to bit of metal and glass here and there. Since I'm not wearing any shoes, I decide not to walk too far in the room.

Rooms 3, 4, and 5 are all the same with varying degrees of family unfriendly content. Room 6 however, is different.

The cryopod in this room is still intact, though opened. There's a journal on the floor, placed directly in the center of the room, laying in such a way that anyone walking in the room would see it immediately, and it's facing them so they'd know to pick it up.

Curious, I walk over to it and pick it up. There's only writing on the first page, so I begin to read it.

Date: Unknown. Location: Unknown. Mental state: Hopeless.

I've been here for a week. I haven't eaten anything. Why are all the other nearby rooms filled with death and violence?! What happened to Anya and Faraday? I met them before entering the cryopod, and I wouldn't forget them since it felt like only an instant before I woke up in this hell. I'm all alone, everyone else is dead.

_No matter what I do, I can hear the drums. The drums keep beating. They come from below. Sometimes I hear screaming. Sometimes I scream. The worst noise is the scratching. I hear the thing walking up and down the corridor, I dare not leave this room or it will get me.

What the hell is going on? I don't want to be here anymore. I miss my husband. Why did I abandon him on a whim? Is this my punishment? Perhaps this is the judgement of God himself. Perhaps that... that **monster** is what I deserve to have end me.

I pause after reading this. Is that the statue monster I first saw? The rest of the page is just rambling with nothing notable.

The next pages all simply say one thing.

It watches.

Over and over again, those two words, on the center of each page, for hundreds of pages, then the journal ends.

I set it down on the floor and say another prayer. I don't know what happened to that woman, but I certainly hope she found peace.

But those words. "It watches." I've felt something watching me since I got here. The eyes follow me everywhere I go. There is no refuge. I leave the 6th room, closing it gently behind me.

The next three rooms hold no surprises. All their occupants are torn to shreds and their cryopods eviscerated. Prayers for all of them, of course.

Walking down the hall, I reach the final door, the one at the end wall. This door is directly opposite from where I first entered the hallway, and it seems to be significant. There's writing on this door as well.

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I didn't notice it the first time I came through here. Could that be significant? Had it simply appeared since the last time I came through here?

Ignoring this, I take a deep breath and press my hand against the door. Unlike the others, it slides open easily. As the door opens. Something takes hold of me.

Confusion. Terror. Panic. These fill my mind. The room has four pillars and a completely intact cryopod in it. But there were only ten cryopods to start with. And curiously, the cryopod is to my right, with another door to the left.

I walk up to the cryopod and notice that there's a small hatch opened on the back of it. The hatch is empty. My hands start shaking. This isn't... no, it can't be...

I walk to the door in this room. There are markings on the door. I've seen these markings before.

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This room. This is my original Cryopod room. But the door that I just entered through was not here before.

Part 013:

I have two choices now.

Somehow, I have looped back around to my original starting location. There is probably a statue monster in this area. But the door that got me here did not exist before.

This place defies the laws of known physics. Somehow, and this sounds absurd, the structure of this place must have changed. The door that got me in this room was not here originally, I'm somewhat sure of that. And the writing on the door was also not there when I first saw it.

This place changes. That has to be the answer. It doesn't make any sense, but neither does shooting light and fire out of my hands. And if it's changing, then I have three logical options.

I don't like options 2 and 3. There's probably a fucking statue monster waiting to eat me, and I'm not sure the extent of my abilities would save me as I currently am. So I decide to try out the first option.

Walking back down the corridor towards the El-Dorado room, I step into it and find...

It has changed. This is not the El-Dorado room. This is something else.

A great fountain is in the middle of this room. I step into the room and walk towards the fountain. My breath catches as I see that the fountain is not bubbling up water in great torrents, but *liquid gold*. Flowing liquid gold spouts up through the top of the fountain, and is recycled up and through the bottom of it to come out the top again.

The fountain itself though, that is what is truly interesting. It's a fountain of a lovely lady, clothed in only her skin. Her right palm is stretched upwards, like she's trying to rest it on the ceiling, 50 feet above her. The water bubbles up and out of her hand, trickling down her body and coming to rest in a pool surrounding her feet.

And in her left hand, there is a glowing black orb clasped firmly. It looks to be exactly the opposite color of my orb. My orb projects a strong light, but hers projects a strong darkness, the two energies of our orbs fighting amongst each other for dominance of the room.

The floor, interestingly, is covered in grass. Actual grass, with flowers here and there. Everywhere her darkness touches, the grass and flowers are dead, and if I move closer, the light from my orb heals them and bring the grass and flowers to life.

Above her sits a golden chandelier with hundreds of unlit candles. A mighty golden door, 20 feet tall, sits on the opposite side of the room from me.

I'm so tired of doors. I'd give anything to never see another door again.

"Do you desire it?"

A voice speaks to me, in the back of my mind. Who was that?

"Do I desire... what?"

The voice... smiles. It somehow grins evilly inside my mind. "Do you desire the power to rule life and death?"

"No." I say flatly. "I desire pizza."

Part 014:

The voice falters. "Are... you denying me?"

"Yeah." I say plainly. "You can piss off. I want to go back home, go to sleep, eat pizza, and never think about this place ever again."

The voice fills with contempt. "You are a fool. All have accepted my offer and ended up in positions of power and fame. Why would you think you are too good for me?"

"It's not that I'm too good for you." I say this to the void, still having no idea where this voice is coming from. I suspect it's the pitch black orb clasped in the statue's hand, but I can't honestly tell. "It's that I don't trust any weird monster voice speaking in my head."

"Yet you seem to trust Hoarhiim, my counterpart." The voice somehow mentally licks its lips. How am I receiving such weird mental images. "You are not just a fool, you are a hypocritical fool. You desire power but fail to admit this to yourself. You're blinded by naivety."

I frown, physically and mentally. "Are you that orb over there? The black one? Are you talking about my bright orb over here? I still have no idea what is going on."

"INSOLENCE!" The voice booms in my mind. "How DARE you call me a black orb, I am Blaarjiim, the mighty Lord of Darkness! Have respect for your elders or I will strike you down where you stand!"

"That won't be possible." Another voice appears in my mind. It's a soft one, this time decidedly the same as the voice I felt earlier in the bedroom. It must be coming from Hoarhiim, the orb of light in my hand. "As long as this one is under my protection, you have no power over this one unless you can get them to purposefully accept your power."

"Hoarhiim... you meddling little..." Blaarjiim trails off.

"Why do you want to give me power anyway?" I ask Blaarjiim. "Seems like a raw deal for you. Are you just lonely?"

"L-LONELY?! Again with the insolence and disrespect! Hoarhiim, now I see why you picked this one, you would do anything to take a shot at me!" Blaarjiim's voice is quivering with rage.

I pause to consider the weird scene I am in. Two sentient orbs of spiritual energy unheard of except in stories and movies are having a heated argument over me, a lowly insolent human. One of them apparently likes me enough to turn me into a wizard, the other one wants to kill me but can't, because I'm a wizard or something.

"Listen, if you promise not to misbehave, I can take you along with me and Hoarhiim and we can have a little adventure together." I say this pointedly at the black orb and the mental face in my mind actually seems to consider this, then it grins evilly again.

"So... you do admit to desiring my power. A wise choice, one you will soon come to love." Blaarjiim grinned, pleased with himself. He'd truly outwitted the lowly mortal once again, as he always had done. Every poor fool fell for the trick. Luckily, Hoarhiim never interfered or warned the idiot saps, since he was a non-interventionist.

"I think you're getting the wrong idea." I said flatly. "I'm not going to take any of your power or anything, I just figured you might want to come along with us and check out the place. Get a load of the sights or something. You know, get out and stretch a bit."

There was a very long pause. Uncomfortably long.

"Surely... you jest. You just want me to come along without taking even a fraction of my infinite power?"

"Yeah."

"No ulterior motives? No plots to have Hoarhiim strip me of my spiritual energy? No dropping me in the pits of Sheol?"

"Uh, no." I frowned. Pits of Sheol? Was that the actual place of torture and agony I could see roiling around directly below me? They called it fucking *Sheol*?

"I... I've never had someone deny my power before. You are a... curious one. VERY WELL, mortal! I will accept your offer!" I nodded and walked over towards the black orb, pausing for a second before I reached for Blaarjiim. "Hey Hoarhiim, he's not gonna try anything if I touch him, right?"

Hoarhiim shook his head in my mind. "No, if you refuse his power, he has no ability to harm you, especially if I am here."

"Fantastic." I say, and I quickly pluck Blaarjiim out of the statue's hand with my other free hand.

Suddenly I felt an incredible shaking as an earthquake started happening. Blaarjiim beamed an image of a deep broad grin into my mind. "I may not hurt you, but that doesn't mean *they* can't."

Part 015:

From behind me, only somewhat distant, came a sound. A sound of thousands of screams, cries, and moans. A sound like a million warhorses charging down the corridor.

"Uh, uh, Hoarhiim? W-what the hell is that?"

"Oh, hm. That would be the riders, I suppose."

"Come again? The Riders?"

"Yes, Child of Gaia. The Riders of Sheol."

From far down the passage I had entered this room from, I heard their horses whinnying now, along with screams of anger and agony. I couldn't see them yet, but in moments I certainly would.

"ALRIGHT FUCK IT, OFF WE GO!" I screamed, whipping open my knapsack on my back, tossing Blaarjiim in (Much to his rage) and then darting past the fountain towards the great golden door.

That door was one heavy son of a bitch. It weighed a metric fuckton, no joke. I probably couldn't have moved it an inch if it weren't for the power that Hoarhiim gave me deep inside the core of my body. With a powerful heave, I shoved the door slightly open, barely enough to squeeze through. As I slipped through, a quick glance behind me made my blood run cold and my pace quicken. Down the corridor behind me, the screaming was getting much louder as the first Hell Horse and its Rider came into view. A skeleton atop a dark horse, the skeleton wearing black armor and wielding a long scimitar in its right hand, came charging out with multiple other horses directly behind it and I even caught a glimpse of a massive army of undead skeletons without horses wielding a large variety of weapons. Needless to say, I only got a glimpse and that glimpse made me quickly slip through the door and heave it shut with all my adrenaline at once.

My body was shaking in terror once again. "What do I do what do I do what do I do???"

"Calm down, Child of Gaia." Hoarhiim said soothingly in my mind. "That door is impossible for nearly any being but a gate troll or one blessed by me to open. Even if a hundred skeletons put their bodies against it, it would not budge."

"Oh god, please tell me you're not joking." I begged him. Hoarhiim nodded in my mind.

Thank god. I slumped to the ground at the base of the great door. I could hear banging, they were pounding incessantly on the door and it was making my nerves even more jittery, but I

managed to keep it together without going totally mental.

"Where am I? Hoarhiim, Blaarjiim, can you tell me what the hell is going on now?!"

An annoyed face appeared in my mind. Blaarjiim sneered at me. "Puny child, you're here in the domain of the Great Kings and you know nothing of whence you came? I will not answer the questions of a buffoon who... who... stuffs me in a knapsack like a piece of refuse!"

I grimaced. "Sorry, I was in a rush." I pulled Blaarjiim out of my knapsack and held him in my left hand. "Alright, a simpler question then. What are you two? Are you like, brothers, or something?"

Hoarhiim mentally gave me a look of sickness. "Brothers? The thought repulses me."

Blaarjiim nodded sagely. "For once we agree on something, old rival."

I blinked twice. "Rival? Are you guys enemies?"

"No!" both of them responded in unison, making me wince. "We both have the same goal, which is total dominion of the world. We wish to overtake The Great One at the very top and become ruler of this world." Hoarhiim explained this matter of factly, as if taking over the world was such a perfectly natural thing to desire.

"Quiet, idiot! Do not mention The Great One openly ever again! Would you have us sentenced to death?" Blaarjiim chided Hoarhiim, who somehow blushed mentally. Thought-speak was truly interesting.

"My apologies. I spoke too rashly. However, if the Child of Gaia does not know of the existence of... that one, then surely this would be disadvantageous for us, who travel along with them?"

I cut off the inevitable response. "Hold on, Hoarhiim. You keep calling me 'the Child of Gaia'. What does that even mean?"

Blaarjiim raised his eyebrow. "You do not know of the existence of Gaia?"

"Well, I mean yeah, that's another word for 'Earth', right?" I asked this quizzically, but there was a long uncomfortable silence, as Hoarhiim and Blaarjiim both stared at me and then quickly look at each other, quietly communicating with each other in a way I could not listen to.

After several uncomfortable minutes, Blaarjiim mentally turned to me. "This farce has gone on long enough. Who are you, and how do you know of the word 'Earth'?"

Part 016:

I stared at Hoarhiim's orb blankly. "What do you mean? Isn't this Earth?"

Hoarhiim started to say something but Blaarjiim cut him off. "We're not allowed to tell you that. Tell us how you know of that word!"

I stared blankly at Blaarjiim. "What are you talking about? I'm from Earth, and isn't this place Earth? I traveled through time to get here."

Hoarhiim rolled his eyes. "Oh yes, now I remember you saying that before when we had first spoken."

Blaarjiim looked aghast. "Time travel? What a bunch of malarkey! You don't expect us to believe that do you?!"

I felt numb. "It's... true. Why are you guys acting so weird? Can't you tell me what's going on?"

"NO! Absolutely not! You naive child, if you think you can lie to us, think again! We'll get to the bottom of this eventually." Blaarjiim sneered once again. He was so adorable when he was angry.

"Right." I rolled my eyes. "Anyway,- oh, this room!"

I suddenly realized that I had gotten into the room barred by the gold doors, but I hadn't looked around me at all.

To my surprise, the room was almost totally empty. It was only 30 feet wide in any square direction, with three doors, one going forward and two going left and right. There was a Red door to the left, a Blue door straight ahead, and a Yellow door to my right. The room was illuminated by four candles sitting on pedestals, in a square formation, with another simple pedestal in the center of them. And on the pedestal there sat a golden crown, with ten spiked pieces pointing up and a massive ruby set in the center.

According to the special vision I had gained from Hoarhiim, this was one of the pieces of armor I had spotted earlier.

"Hoarhiim, I've been meaning to ask you something since I learned you can speak."

Hoarhiim, also examining the room, turned back to me. "Oh? What might that be?"

"Well, it's regarding our relationship. Originally you said that as long as I didn't specifically request it, Blaarjiim could not harm me, but I also could not use his power either, right?"

"That is correct." Hoarjiim nodded lightly while a bored expression crossed over his face and his eyes wandered around.

"Okay, so with that said, why am I able to use your power? I never asked for this."

"Incorrect." Hoarhiim immediately turned and mentally looked me in the eye. "When you were chased by the shadow, you grabbed ahold of me with fierce determination. You did not have to ask for my power out loud, your heart asked for it loudly. However, if you had yelled 'I do not wish to have your power', I would not have given it to you."

I bobbed my head. "So does that mean I can give up your power if I want?"

"No. Once you partake of the power of either one of us, or both, you are bound to us until one of us dies. If you leave me behind anywhere, and I am somehow slain, you will die as well."

I see. So when I grabbed him, because I didn't immediately declare that I had no desire to have his power, he became bound to me. Then that must mean that if I had grabbed ahold of Blaarjiim without saying I didn't want *his* power, he'd be bound to me as well. Blaarjiim is a troublemaker too, so I had no desire to have him bound to my soul. Plus, I'm not sure of their relationship, but I feel like having the power of both beings inside me would rip me apart, literally and spiritually.

"Hoarhiim." I said, as I approached the pedestal holding the crown. "When I had you in my hand, I gained the ability to shoot light and fire from my hands. Do I have more abilities?"

"You may, or you may not. It all depends on your own power. Blaarjiim and I are only a manifestation of spiritual power that a being may themselves possess. We do not grant power, only amplify latent power. I have given many power, as has Blaarjiim, and every one of them was different."

"I see." I said, as I used a few fingers of the hand holding Blaarjiim to grasp ahold of the golden crown and raise it to the top of my head. "What about the fact that I can see mysterious pieces of armor all over the place, including this one?"

Hoarhiim was silent.

"You can see their locations? Through the walls?" Blaarjiim sounded skeptical.

"Yes. There's a sword, a set of armor, a mighty shield, leg guards, and other such things."

Blaarjiim looked incredulous. "That's not possible. Those are... the lost treasures of the ancient kings. The one in your hand now is worth a million fortunes. To be able to simply see them, you'd have to be... you'd have to... be..." He trailed off again and lowered his eyes.

Hoarhiim nodded quietly. "Maybe you are the one they spoke of."

Part 017: The Crown

I felt fire in my veins.

The instant the crown touched my head, everything became chaotic. All my senses exploded. I was able to smell a hundred times more clearly than a bloodhound. My eyes surged with power, the darkness could hide nothing from my vision. My perception of movement increased tenfold. My body strength was the same as before, but I had never realized just how much latent power Hoarhiim had unlocked inside me. With the Crown on my head, I was suddenly able to comprehend so many more things. Infinite wisdom, too much wisdom for a single mind flooded inside me.

But something strange happened. This power could certainly be called strange, but the instant my mind was able to somewhat adjust to this incredible new flow of information, two words played in my head.

"Solomon's Crown."

Solomon? That's not possible. The one spoken of in the bible? I had never been a big bible reader, but most people knew the story of King Solomon. Said to be favored by God as one of his most trusted servants, he was granted peerless wisdom, allowing him to rule over a vast kingdom with the knowledge befitting a powerful King of Old.

This crown, if this was truly his crown, might it have his knowledge locked inside it? Might I have uncovered an item of horrifying power?

Nevertheless, this new mental prowess astounded me. I could hear things I had not heard before. The lake of acid and fire below me was perceived even more vividly now, I could make out individual faces of people, rising out of the acid, their skin growing back, and then the people falling back into it, melting and burning in agony, a neverending torment.

On top of that, a new mental ability seemingly unlocked itself. "Mental Map", the ability to visualize the world around me as a 3D map, hovering transparently in front of my vision, solidifying only if I wished it.

I could see the maze in its entirety now. I was dead in the center of it. Around me, the maze twisted and bent, walls moving around, hallways shifting to move towards other hallways. Without this crown, I could now see there was no hope of ever escaping this hell. But with it, could anything be possible?

"Solomon's Crown." I said aloud, to nobody in general. Looking to Hoarhiim and then back to Blaarjiim in each of my hands, I stood there stunned. "This cannot truly be the Crown possessed by a king of old, can it?"

"What do you think the answer is?" Asked Hoarhiim. "I may have before seemed a timeless wise ancient deity, but with that crown on your head, you now exceed even my intellect."

It was true. I remember struggling, back in college, to pass a math class. I failed it twice and was going to try one last time, but the teacher had told me: *Stop wasting your money, you are not suited for this.*

But now, that math was children's play. Concepts alien to my mind before began to take shape. Creating dark matter? Simple. Expanding or contracting a black hole? Child's play. King Solomon was limited by the technology of his era, but I was not. My universe had gone far beyond what he could do. Perhaps, had he lived long enough and not fallen to the charms of women, he could have advanced humanity to a new plane of existence with this knowledge.

"Does God exist?" I asked.

"Of course." Replied Hoarhiim. "There's no point hiding it now, you'll soon know it yourself anyway. Soon you'll know everything."

I thought deeply for a while, sitting down on the ground in a meditative position. Suddenly, a thought so humorous came to my mind that I laughed aloud. "Haha, Hoarhiim! You little devil! You knew I could have beaten those monsters with your power, didn't you?"

"The small swarm outside the golden door? Of course. They are of the dark, I am a powerful entity of the light, they would have fallen before me." Hoarhiim sniffled. "I'm sad it took the wisdom of a god to make you realize that."

Now it made sense. He didn't seem worried about them at all. He seemed bored by their appearance. Heck, even I feel bored by them now.

Looking around, I glanced at the other three doors in the room. According to my mental map, they all led to dead ends or deadly traps. Given time, one of them would likely open up to a normal pathway, but I was feeling antsy.

"You know what? Let's take the fun way out."

Part 018:

I walked calmly up to the golden door. The sounds of banging and scratching, neighing and blood-curdling screaming could all be heard. If I didn't know better, I'd say they were planning a party for my arrival.

I smirked at the thought of what was to come next. But then I faltered. Looking at the big door, I realized it only opened inwards, and it had no handles.

I sat down to think about how to approach this.

Some time passed as I thought about how to proceed. I could just wait for the next rooms to line up. Pulling up my Mental Map, I examined it closely. The maze was as wide as it was tall. It went up above me for several hundred miles, and below me for another few hundred. There were several exits to the outer world, whatever it may look like, but getting there would take forever.

The locations of the King Class items were scattered all over, a few somewhat nearby, some very far away, but none of them were going to be gained today.

Setting both orbs on the ground in front of me, I turned to Hoarhiim. "Hey, this is a strange question, but do I need to be touching you to use your power?"

Hoarhiim shrugged in my mind. "I dunno, what do you think the answer is?"

I shrugged too. Raising my hand towards the door, I spoke. " **Light.** "

Well, I may have Solomon's crown, but I'm not used to his wisdom yet apparently. The light reflected off the golden door and blasted back into my eyes. "OW! FUCK! SON OF A BITCH!" I howled in pain as my super-sensitive eyesight made me recoil in agony.

After rolling around on the ground for a few minutes in pain, I pulled myself up, blinking profusely.

"Alright Hoarhiim, I'm beginning to see why you like this one." said Blaarjiim with a chuckle. "Certainly provides much amusement."

"Shut up, asshole." I said, snarling at the black orb. "It was an honest mistake."

"Yeah, but it didn't take a super genius to see that coming from a mile away." Smirked Hoarhiim. "I guess it's true what they say, you have to learn from your mistakes."

After some time passed I stood up, wrapping Hoarhiim and Blaarjiim inside of fabric torn from my knapsack. Depositing its original contents on the ground, I look them over. I still don't know or want to know what's inside those cans, the flashlight is no longer needed, and none of

the other stuff is really all that useful to me. Using the rusty knife to slowly hack away at the knapsack's nylon cords, I end up wrapping that rope I had saved from the Cryopod around my waist and letting Hoarhiim and Blaarjiim dangle on either side of me inside their new hanging pouch.

"Alright guys, sorry for closing you off like this, but you can see through my eyes anyway, right Hoarhiim?"

Hoarhiim nodded.

"Hey! What about me! I'm not bound to you! I can't see anything inside this prison you've put me in! I need air!" Blaarjiim started ranting about his poor living conditions. I sighed.

"Alright, I'll cut a little slit so you can see, just be careful and let me know if you fall. I would hate to, uh, 'accidentally' leave you behind."

Blaarjiim murmured and grumbled but finally accepted that a slit was the best he'd get.

Despite being in a pouch, Hoarhiim's light was still very bright as the thin nylon did little to block his radiance. He was like having a very bright sun attached to my 'belt' loop.

"Alright guys, I have a plan. And it starts with killing a whole lot of undead nightmares." I grinned. This was gonna be good.

Part 019: Revenge

I had this silly idea in my mind, and well, it probably won't work, but it can't hurt to try.

Standing about 15 feet away from the door, I raise my palm up and aim it at the door. A word begins to form in my mind.

"Push."

A wave of energy spreads out of my body and surges towards the door, hitting it, causing it to groan a tiny bit, and then it all stops.

"Damn. It didn't work." I grimace. "Maybe I need more power."

Rooting myself firmly in my spot with a solid stance, I speak the word again this time, but with more force.

" **Push.** "

A much stronger wave blasts out of my body, hitting the door, causing it to noticeably rattle. The incessant pounding, wailing, and screaming that I had heard up to now from the other side of the door suddenly stops. The air becomes perfectly still.

"This time, it will work." I say aloud, as Hoarhiim and Blaarjiim look on in interest.

Rooting myself firmly in place, I gather a colossal amount of air in my lungs, and belt the word out again.

"PUUUUUUSH!"

An absolutely stupendous amount of energy blasts out of my body. I was standing far too close to the door. The blast sends me flying backwards, smashing into the 5 pillars behind me, crushing them into dust when they hit the ground thanks to the power of my impact.

As bad as I was, the door was far worse. It blasted outwards, smashing away all the monsters directly in its path and crushing many more as it flew off its hinges and careened across the room. It crushed several Skeleton Commanders (I knew their names thanks to the Crown) and sent the rest of the enemy who weren't instantly killed running away, shrieking in terror.

It's a good thing too. I was beaten up pretty badly. "Holy... fucking shit...." I said, unceremoniously. "Oh god, everything hurts."

Blaarjiim burst out laughing. "GWAHAHAHA! THAT WAS THE FUNNIEST THING I'VE EVER SEEN!" I could just imagine him slapping his knees repeatedly as he rocked back and

forth in a rocking chair. "You went flying like a little birdie straight into those pillars! That was easily the best thing you've done yet!"

Hoarhiim was laughing too, though to a lesser extent, more of a quiet giggle. "You sure showed those monsters who's boss. But be glad none of them saw you or you'd be-"

Suddenly Hoarhiim stopped laughing and his face stiffened. "Wait. They aren't all gone yet. One approaches."

I jerked my head up to look at the doorway. In the doorway was a little girl, just a small child.

"Hello there. What's your name?"

Part 020: Amelia

"I'm Amelia!" said the little girl cheerfully. She came running over to me crumpled among the pillars. My mind was racing and I was panicking. My body was almost destroyed and I had no way to fight back. What is a little girl doing running around this hellish maze? She's definitely some kind of soul sucking Chucky Doll.

"G-get back!" I yell as one of my arms flails for a second and then drops down. I have literally no ability to move right now. I'm totally helpless.

"Blaarjiim, is that you?" asked the little girl quizzically as she totally ignores my presence, staring at the orb inside the pouch affixed to my rope belt. How can you even see in there? Did this mean person kidnap you and do bad things to you?" She stuck her tongue out at me. "Bleehhh! What a meanie head!"

A... meanie head? What is up with this girl? How does she know Blaarjiim?

"Ah Amelia, so good to see you in your real body again. How have you been?" Blaarjiim greeted the child cheerfully. I guess he knows her.

"Amelia! Splendid! It's been a long time!" Hoarhiim also chimed in. I guess they both know her, huh?

"Uh, you guys know her?" I asked weakly.

"Duh! We're like the bestest friends ever!" said Amelia, as she hunched over me and reached for Blaarjiim. But then she paused. "Hold on a second, Hoarhiim, you're linked to this person, but Blaarjiim, you aren't?"

Blaarjiim nodded angrily. "Yes! That's right! I was denied! The Child of Gaia refused to accept my power and bound me inside this prison, only allowing me to see but a small part of the world!" Blaarjiim let out clearly fake sobbing noises. Nobody could possibly fall for this lame act.

"Oh gosh, Blaarjiim, that's terrible! I must rescue you at once!"

She fell for it.

Quickly undoing his strands, Amelia grabbed hold of Blaarjiim and cupped him tightly to her chest. "Oh Blaarjiim, we're not going to be separated ever again! I accept your power!"

A huge surge of energy swept from Blaarjiim into Amelia as she giggled and danced around with the orb in her hands. It was kind of cute in a weird way.

Then she stopped dancing and her smile evaporated. Her face and body went totally cold as she looked at me. "So, what person dares hurt my eternal lover?"

Part 21 Oh god, please don't suck my soul, crazy little demon girl. That kept replaying in my head as the suddenly very evil looking little girl slowly walked towards me, a look of a serial killer on her face with a glint of bloodlust mixed in.

"N-now now! I think there has maybe been a small mix-up?" My legs shifted as I tried to pull myself up to get away from her but my body was still in bad condition.

"Amelia, calm down." Said Blaarjiim. "I was just joking, my dear. The Child of Gaia is not our enemy."

Instantly, the look of Satan left her face and a cheerful smile spread across it. "Okay! If you say so Blaarjiim! Teehee!" She smiled happily and danced over towards me, coming to a sitting position right in front of my splayed out body. "By the way, you look like you're in a lot of pain. Does that, uh, hurt?"

"Yes." I groaned, eager to change the subject. "I can't move anything. I think I broke every bone in my body. I'm probably going to die here."

There was yet another uncomfortable silence as both orbs and the little girl narrowed their eyes and stared at me. I didn't like the feeling. "W-what? Did I say something stupid?"

"Yes..." Hoarhiim replied. "You have the infinite power of a supreme being inside your body and the wisdom of an ancient king pouring through your mind, but you're still surprisingly stupid sometimes."

I blushed, feeling slightly embarrassed, and then realized what he meant.

"Oh, uh, right." Carefully raising my right wrist, I aimed my palm slowly towards my body.

" **Heal** ".

I instantly felt 30% better. My broken bones weren't fixed much, but the pain eased and I was able to take a much deeper breath. Steeling myself again, I tried again, this time with more force.

" **HEAL!** "

The shock of the healing was actually more painful than the initial impact into the pillars. My bones violently mended themselves, jamming together at a maniacally fast pace, my cuts and bruises instantly disappearing. I jumped to my feet and suddenly felt very weak, falling forward and missing Amelia by inches.

"Ahh... what the hell... why am I so... weak? I can't move at all even though I'm healed." Looking up at Amelia I noticed she was rolling her eyes.

"Duh, stupid. If you use all your spiritual energy to heal yourself, you'll be lucky if you don't die immediately afterwards. You're very brash."

A thought crossed my mind. "Wait, spiritual energy? That's really what that is?"

Hoarhiim nodded. "That is correct. You have a most interesting way of using my power. You're the first being to have gained my abilities that uses words to formulate magical concepts. Most others reach inside the Thought Energy to pull out their desired attack. You even somehow make the force of your words somehow amplify the effect. Whatever it is that you're doing though, it seems to have some serious side effects."

Blaarjiim looked my exhausted body up and down. "It's interesting, this one doesn't tap inside the limitless power of thought energy, but instead pulls from within themselves. It allows for a more explosive amount of power, but the amount of energy available is much smaller and more finite, and it seems to drain from the Child of Gaia's own body."

"I concur." said Hoarhiim in the affirmative. "A very unique ability, with more power able to be used at once, but also much more risk to their life. Such an interesting child."

Their words didn't escape me. Mentally, I was perfectly fine. Despite having practically no energy or ability to move inside my body, my mind was fully awake and seemingly boundless in energy. It would seem that I was in some fantastical place where the laws of physics were either nonexistent, or significantly different. Nevertheless, the concept of energy conservation seemed to exist. To give to one thing, you must take from another.

"Say, this thought energy you guys keep mentioning, what is it? How do I tap into it?"

Amelia smiled. "You can't!"

Helpful. Thanks a lot for that truly detailed and concise answer. "I can't? Why not?"

"We're not sure." said Blaarjiim. "You appear to be an aberration. Most beings pull from the Thought Energy almost instinctually, you completely bypass it. You would appear to be cut off from it."

I grimaced. Unlimited power was not within my grasp. Still though... "But you said my power was more explosive? So that means I have a much higher possible amount of power, but also a much lower minimum?"

"Yes, your power is more wild. It's hard to get a good grasp on. You are an interesting creature, to be sure." Blaarjiim projected a mental image of stroking his chin.

We chatted for a few minutes more and after Amelia propped my numb body up against the wall, an obvious question crossed my mind. "Hey, Amelia, I just realized that I have no idea where you came from. Were you mixed in with those monsters from earlier?"

Amelia shook her head and cracked a big smile. "Nope! I was trapped inside the statue, but you freed me when you destroyed my container!"

I looked past her and out the gaping door. The statue was in pieces on the ground, shattered into a thousand fragments by the impact of the massive golden doors.

What the hell? She was inside a statue? What the fuck is up with this place and statues? Why are they all so freaky? Next statue I see, I'm going to talk to it like it's a real person.

Looking my own body up and down, I turned my head towards Hoarhiim. "Well... what do we do now then?"

Hoarhiim raised his head to the ceiling thoughtfully. "I have an idea."

Part 021:

Oh god, please don't suck my soul, crazy little demon girl. That kept replaying in my head as the suddenly very evil looking little girl slowly walked towards me, a look of a serial killer on her face with a glint of bloodlust mixed in.

"N-now now! I think there has maybe been a small mix-up?" My legs shifted as I tried to pull myself up to get away from her but my body was still in bad condition.

"Amelia, calm down." Said Blaarjiim. "I was just joking, my dear. The Child of Gaia is not our enemy."

Instantly, the look of Satan left her face and a cheerful smile spread across it. "Okay! If you say so Blaarjiim! Teehee!" She smiled happily and danced over towards me, coming to a sitting position right in front of my splayed out body. "By the way, you look like you're in a lot of pain. Does that, uh, hurt?"

"Yes." I groaned, eager to change the subject. "I can't move anything. I think I broke every bone in my body. I'm probably going to die here."

There was yet another uncomfortable silence as both orbs and the little girl narrowed their eyes and stared at me. I didn't like the feeling. "W-what? Did I say something stupid?"

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Looking my own body up and down, I turned my head towards Hoarhiim. "Well... what do we do now then?"

Hoarhiim raised his head to the ceiling thoughtfully. "I have an idea."

Part 022: Conviction

Hoarhiim nodded thoughtfully. "What you need to do is get stronger. With your destruction of the Riders of Sheol and causing an embarrassment to the Lord of the Undead, she won't forget this slight easily. She's probably going to send more at you. As you are right now, you will surely die."

Lord of the undead huh? That sounded ominous. I'm getting a *bad* feeling about this. "Well, for now, I need to rest my body. If only there was a safe room somewhere nearby."

Amelia smiled. "Ha! There's no such thing as a safe room! There is always danger inside the Labyrinth!" Saying that, she grabbed my hand, jumped to her feet, and with her other hand, made some strange symbols in the air.

Wait, what the hell? Suddenly I was inside a room with a bed, a large Victorian-Style bed, to be precise. Was this the safe room from earlier?

"Uh, uh, how did we get here? I'm confused." I looked around in bewilderment. It had happened so fast! I was leaning against the wall in the room with the pillars and then suddenly I was here.

"It's teleportation, *obviously*," Amelia replied, mocking me condescendingly. "Sheesh, for a person with such power and wisdom, you truly are a buffoon."

"Yes, I'm always amazed at the sheer stupidity I witness constantly." Blaarjiim nodded in the affirmative. Shut up, asshole.

"Teleportation huh? This place has less limits than I thought." I thought about it for a minute. If we could teleport, then all bets were off. Did I even need to actually travel the maze? Why not just teleport to each of the legendary treasures? I knew where they were all located. If I could figure out how to use it, teleporting should be pretty easy.

Hoarhiim, apparently reading my mind thanks to our linked energy, shook his head. "Bad idea, Child. If you go teleporting around, you'll be dead in seconds. Not only does danger lurk at every turn in this Labyrinth, it takes a vast amount of energy to move even a small distance. Furthermore, most legendary treasures are hidden inside a Thought Sphere, protecting them from magical interference. This is also why it baffles me that you can see their locations. It shouldn't be possible."

Amelia smiled. "Unlike you, I have access to thought energy, and my dear Blaarjiim would never let me get hurt so I'm not worried about it! Plus I'm not a weakling like you." She made a

weird motion with her hands to her face like she was imitating me. I'd rather not describe it. How rude.

Alright already. I think I have an idea of what needs to be done. I need to find more pieces of that armor. This should make me very formidable. The only question is, what piece should I target next? Looking at the rooms in my Mental Map, I searched around carefully. The Chestplate and the Leg Bracers seem to be the closest, with the latter being the absolute closer of them, but if this twisty maze is any indication, that could change over the course of a few days if my luck doesn't hold out.

However, there's also the matter of my accidentally enraging the Lord of the Undead. I guess whoever she is, she's different from being the Lord of Darkness, like Blaarjiim? How many lords are there? Do they have different abilities? How can I protect myself against them? How can I defeat them or avoid them, or even just make peace with them?

An idea forms in my mind. When I entered here, I was hopeless. Death awaited around every corner, but now, I feel more than just hope. I may just have a goal. Not just to escape this hell, but barring that, to rule over this labyrinth. What if I were to defeat and subjugate all the lords around me? What if by becoming ruler I could gain a power that would allow me to return to my own time or world, wherever that may be.

Would I even want to do that? My life was dull. It was boring. Before I came here, I was so tired of my world that I was willing to put myself inside a cryopod and send myself into a fantastically distant future, caring nothing for anyone I'd leave behind.

Yes, it's true. I don't miss my old world at all. The only reason I wanted to return was due to my cowardice. Since this crown has effectively removed my cowardice, I can think more clearly and formulate strategy more effectively.

I look Amelia right in the eye. "Amelia, I have an idea for a game we can play."

Part 023:

Goddamn, I am sick to fucking death of chicken.

I took a full three days to recuperate in the bed, so badly had I exhausted myself. Every so often, Amelia would bounce into the room and give me a plate of chicken to eat. I'm beyond being sick of chicken. I'd rather eat the bones of a skeleton at this point.

Amelia seems to take a perverse delight in my suffering. Every time she hears me complain about all the chicken, she gets a wide grin on her face and tries to stuff more in my face.

Nevertheless, as awful as it is, by the third day, I'm back to my usual cheerful boundless self. Just kidding, I'm never cheerful.

"Alright, Amelia. Let's head out."

Gathering Hoarhiim and tying him around myself as I had before, Amelia and I step out of the front door and walk down the hallway. I'm now wearing some shoes Amelia made for me, along with a light tunic made out of fabric she stripped from the bed sheets. It's not exactly fashionable but I'll deal with it. I even got a nice bath after Amelia showed me how to make said bath appear in our bathroom. I am clean and wearing 'new' clothes. It's time for action.

When we exit the room and walk down the hallway, we end up in the El-Dorado room from before. I get an idea and decide to inquire about it. "Hoarhiim, when I first arrived here, there was a terrifying statue that was outside my door. I returned later and it was gone, and I'm just wondering if it was alive."

"It's hard to say." said Hoarhiim, mentally shrugging. Statues are created by the Lords of this labyrinth. Typically they were used in the Elder Ages to encase their foes in an inescapable prison, but recently they've been used for surveillance, security, and even defense. The real problem comes from a statue's spiritual power."

"Oh, are they strong?" The thought made me shudder.

"Strong? They're incredibly strong. Once transformed into a statue, reinforcement magic is many times more powerful, both for offense and defense. Their bodies can be nigh indestructible." Hoarhiim wagged his mental finger at me.

I glanced at Amelia. "But wasn't she a statue as well? How did she escape?"

Hoarhiim looked at me meaningfully. "You possess an explosive power. That much should be apparent. Just... don't get cocky."

I nodded aggressively. Right, so I have the power to destroy the indestructible. Good to know.

Looking around the El-Dorado room and comparing it with my Mental Map, I had a silly idea. It definitely wouldn't work.

"Detect."

I said this word and looked around me. I knew that my power came from single words, any more than one word and the spell always failed. Unfortunately, this made it difficult for me to come up with more advanced concepts.

It seemed to work, just not in the way I expected. I could see little dots moving around, all well past the walls. There was a lot of them, some dots concentrated, some dots all alone. They appeared to almost be an illusion. I can't tell what they are, but since they're moving, they might be monsters. The biggest problem I have is that the dots give no idea of their distance. They could be right around the corner or hundreds of miles away.

"Cancel."

Formulating the word in my mind, and directing the energy towards my previous request, the dots disappear. I can vaguely control how things happen with my mind, but the concept is fairly abstract right now. Plenty of experimentation during my three days of sleep helped expand my knowledge of my abilities, but I'm still a novice playing with very dangerous fire.

"It's settled then. I want to answer a certain question that's been nagging me." With that, I spun around and walked out the hall of El-Dorado, up a long hallway that was sure to lead me to my old nemesis. Amelia bounced along behind me, with Blaarjiim cupped in her hands.

Once I end this fear, I can move on to greater things.

Part 024:

We exited the El-Dorado room, leaving behind mountains of gold and jewels, and headed up the long hallway. It no longer curved, now it was straight. Exiting it, we found ourselves outside that same familiar colossal door I had first seen what felt like an eternity ago. The door was covered in moonspeak now, which had changed since the last time I came through here. However, thanks to Solomon's Crown, I was able to read them.

None shall enter.

Strange. Did this crown give me knowledge of languages as well? That would be fortunate if it did. This crown was like a cheat code, it gave me too much mental prowess.

We continued walking away from the doors. *None shall enter*, huh? I'll have to come back to that room in the future for sure.

Walking down the hallway, Amelia was happily chatting with Blaarjiim as if I didn't even exist. "It was so boring being locked up inside that statue! I'm glad you stayed with me though, and I was never bored since we could talk all day long!"

"True, but being able to get out and stretch must have felt a great deal better." Blaarjiim seemed cheerful. Odd, when I first met him, he was always mad, always going on about being the Lord of Darkness, but now that Amelia was here, he was pretty chill. He seemed like a nice enough deity, or whatever he was.

At the end of the hall we reached the door that looked like the one I came from. It was hard to tell with the shifting halls, but this was probably it. However, the door was shut, and it opened inwards, towards me. It also had no handles.

"Should I just break it down again?" I asked nobody in particular. I instantly decided that was a horrible idea. Then I had a new idea.

Putting my palm outwards, I aimed it at the door.

" Pull. "

Instead of blasting out of me, energy was sucked in from all around me, making the door rattle and then pull outwards. It also pulled in many other things around me, including Amelia, who was lifted up off the ground and flew at me.

"Ahhh!" she let out a little yelp and smacked me square in the body, knocking both of us on the ground in a heap. "A little WARNING next time!"

I grimaced. "Sorry. I'm not used to this yet."

"Yeah! No kidding." Getting up, she brushed herself off, wiping her skirt down and fanning it to look more modest.

Then we turned to look inside the room I'd just opened.

It was empty.

I felt disappointed. Perhaps the scary statue monster from before wasn't here. We entered the room, looking around. Amelia pointed at the ceiling. "Look. A hole." I jerked my head up. It was the same square hole I remembered seeing when I came here. This was the same room.

The floor was no longer covered in moonspeak though. Neither were the walls. Why were they gone? What made them come and go? Was it my presence? We walked further into the room and examined the door leading to -what I presumed was- my original Cryopod room.

I put my hand up to cast the 'pull' magic again.

At that moment, the door behind us slammed shut with incredible force.

" So. You've returned. "

Part 025: Monster

There was no statue monster behind me. Instead, there was an old man, standing up straight. The old man was at least 7 feet tall, a good head taller than me and significantly taller than Amelia. He was wearing a pure black suit with a pure black tie. It was hard to tell details apart, it all kind of blended together with the rest of his outfit.

What was terrifying, however, was his eyes. The man's eyes glowed a fiery red. "Beelzebub. You may refer to me as Beelzebub."

He's a goddamn demon? I started to pipe up but Hoarhiim instantly interrupted me. "Ah, Lord of Fire, great Beelzebub! So great to see you! Allow me to introduce this one, his name is the Child of Gaia."

That wasn't actually my name but at this point, I might as well just stick with it. Nobody cared about my original name, it was too boring and plain in a world of demons and monsters anyway.

"Yes, I know of this person. *We* all do. You've caused quite the ruckus, child. Have anything to say for yourself?" His glowing red eyes betrayed no emotion. His voice was cold as ice, despite being the Lord of Fire.

"Ah, well, I did a bit of this, and that, and I just sort of... ended up here!" I said, nervously chattering my teeth as his cold unending gaze directed itself into my soul. "I kind of did some uh, stuff, and well I got a little bit of this and that, you know?"

"Hm. Yes. Gressil was the first one to note your arrival. You were weak and pathetic. And yet here you stand, with a legendary treasure worn as if it is but a trifle." Beelzebub glared at the crown on my head. "It disgusts me that a mere... human... would wear such a powerful artifact as Solomon's Crown, but once you've put it on, it cannot be removed by anyone other than you, except in death."

He really didn't seem to like me. I feel like my existence was an affront to his very nature. Also, that name, Gressil...

"Gressil? Is that... that couldn't be the statue I witnessed when I first entered, could it?" I don't know why I was asking a question at a time like this. I shouldn't make this demon mad. I knew that in my heart.

"Yes... Gressil is the... statue, you first saw." Beelzebub tucked up the corner of his mouth, almost in a smile. "Be glad that it was me you found. Do not seek out Gressil if you value your

life. You can only ever see him once. If you see him again, you are cursed to die."

I gulped audibly. I nearly committed a grave mistake coming here.

"Heyyyy Beelzebub! How are you~ ♪!" Amelia leaned forwards and waved energetically at him. That girl was afraid of nothing. Who was she anyway? "Long time no see! How is the missus?!"

Beelzebub visibly cringed. I couldn't tell if it was because of the question or if it was just that Beelzebub hated Amelia. "Ah... Lady Amelia, Lord of Flies. Always a... pleasure to see you." This was clearly not a pleasure for him. There's no way she'll fall for it.

"Aww, thank you! You're always so sweet to me!" She fell for it.

"Lord Beelzebub, why have you come here?" Hoarhiim had not yet joined the conversation but now he felt he had something worth asking.

"To deliver a warning. *She* is looking for you. I find that this child will provide some amusement and if the child dies too soon, it will be boring once again."

Hoarhiim nodded slowly. "You Lords are always trying to either rise to the position of King or fight amongst each other."

Beelzebub shifted his position and adjusted his tie. "You're one to speak. You and Hoarhiim sealed yourselves inside those accursed orbs to condense your power and play games with adventurers. Now you can't even walk normally among the land of the living."

"It was a smart choice." Blaarjiim chimed in. "Our power is magnified a hundred-fold. We now far outclass even you."

"Yes, but you can only use your power through a vessel, and you have no ability to control said vessel. Not even the brains to make them mind controlled. So stupid." Beelzebub sneered.

"Hey! Don't call my lover stupid! YOU'RE STUPID! Bleeehhh!" Amelia stuck her tongue out at him. Is she really trying to pick a fight with a demon?

"Well, I've done my duty. You stand corrected and now know to tread lightly. Don't die too quickly or my fun will end." Beelzebub gave a small bow. He had totally ignored Amelia.

It felt odd, having a demon with fiery eyes bow to me. I bowed awkwardly too, and Amelia curtsied. "Have a great day, Beelzebub!" she shouted cheerfully, apparently already over his insult towards Hoarhiim and Blaarjiim.

What happened next made me doubt reality. One second, Beelzebub was there, and the next instant, he was gone. He just popped out of existence. No chanting of a spell, no movement of

his hands, he simply instantly teleported, and didn't even leave behind a trail of smoke or anything else.

And then I heard something. The sound of feet. *Lots of feet.*

Part 026: Feet In The Deep

From that tiny hole in the roof there came a noise of many small pitter-pattering feet.

"What could that be?" I found myself wondering out loud. It was a small hole, only a foot wide, and it was square. With such a small hole, nothing threatening could really come out of it.

And just as I had that thought, out came a small army of lizardmen, really tiny little guys, sticking to the ceiling like geckos. They started funneling out of the hole and spreading out in every which direction. Soon the entire room was filled with them, along with the ceiling and walls and both doors. They were really tiny, a little under a foot tall, about the size of small housecats. They all had tiny swords and shovels and axes and by gosh they were just the cutest little things, even though they had mean looks on their faces.

I heard a voice near my feet squeak and hiss at me. "You there! Fleshbag!" I looked down. Most of the lizardmen were green, but a few off-colored ones were at my feet. The one speaking was a purple one, and he wore a little teeny tiny crown and a royal raiment of some sort. He was definitely the leader.

"I am King Ghidorah! Speak your name!" Ghidorah spoke to me. That's odd, up until now everyone I've met has either had demonic names, odd names that are hard to pronounce, or in the case of Amelia, perfectly normal names. But this was the first time I'd heard a name from a popular Japanese movie series. Though... considering the moonspeak around here... it did make sense...

"I am Gaia's Child." I said, trying to sound reverent and respectful towards the itty bitty lizard at my feet. A pleasure to meet you, though I do wonder if you're here to attack me?"

The lizard suddenly shook in fright. "Attack you?! Attack the great and holy Child of Gaia who will overturn the balance of the labyrinth?! No way! It could never happen! We are the Children of Marie, and we are here to serve all who come from the magic containers! They shall be our salvation!" He seemed genuinely scared of me. A quick glance at the nearby lizards made me realize that they were all in some form of a position involving head bowing.

"Oh gosh, he's soooo adorable! Can we keep him? Can we?" Amelia jumped in the conversation, ignoring me. "I've never seen the Children of Marie before, they're so reclusive and only live in the shadows! But now that I see you I just want to gobble you up!"

The lizardmen near her suddenly leaped in near the king. "Ah, my lord! She wishes to attack and devour us! Your commands?"

The other lizardmen in the cave suddenly went on high alert. Amelia's vocabulary had made an odd situation tense. "Ah, no, I think she was using a euphemism for..." "I paused for a second to find a good word, any word. "...kissing! Yes, she loves kissing lizards."

Turning my head quickly to Amelia, grinning hard and nodding my head vigorously while looking for a quick agreement, I saw a face of pure and utter disgust aimed at me. *Please don't say anything that might offend them. Please don't upset this conversation.* I mentally sent images of a man begging at her, but she didn't receive them.

"Um, no, I don't want to kiss lizards. Ewwww! I do want to pet and play with them though!" She brightened up and smiled big at that last statement. The lizardmen around her visibly relaxed. Somehow she had cleared the air.

Directing my attention back to the King, I spoke again. "Great King Ghidorah, you say that you are the Child of Marie, but who is this Marie that you speak of?"

He smiled a toothy reptile grin and beamed solemn happiness at me. "Ah, Marie! She is the great goddess, the first fleshbag to show kindness to us! Where before the others showed us only fear and hate, she treated us as equals and stopped the infighting amongst our clans! She was one of the later occupants of a magic container!" The king nodded excitedly.

A sudden thought crossed my mind. It couldn't be. "Magic Container? You mean a cryopod? She was someone who came from a cryopod?"

"Yes! That was what she called it! She emerged and we gave her protection, now she benevolently rules over us, from somewhere in the labyrinth!"

I suddenly felt chills roll down my spine. Someone from a Cryopod was still here? I was not alone?

Part 027: History

I still know nothing of this world. I know what this world is (A labyrinth) but I don't know where, why, or how. Nothing makes sense. Every time I learn something new, more questions appear.

But now, something earth shattering has happened. I've found out that another cryopod survivor may exist. I'm not alone here. Based on the rooms that I saw, it could only be one person, the room with the journal. Perhaps that is why she left it behind. But there was no name in the journal, so it might not be her. Who am I kidding? It has to be her. There were only ten people put in cryopods, and 8 of them died gruesome deaths.

I pause that thought. Only ten? What if there were more? This labyrinth is massive. More could have been sent after us. Come to think of it, this doesn't feel like the same universe, given the lack of laws of physics. The law of conservation seems to be in effect, but not the law of physics.

And there's the matter of the lake of acid and fire deep below me. Those are decidedly human souls. If there was ever a description of Hell, that would be it. Was this the future? I can't imagine I'm actually in the future. What if the scientists lied to us. What if something else was done and we ended up here? We could have been like the Mayflower to the Americas, just an initial scouting crew.

And if we did not time travel, then this begs the question, why did they lie to us? Surely knowledge of any kind about what we were going to get ourselves into would have spared us many deaths. But maybe they didn't want to spare our lives. Maybe...

I ignore that thought. Nothing good will come of this line of reasoning.

"King Ghidorah." I look down at him, right in his eyes. "Would it be possible for me to meet Marie?"

"No, I am afraid that is not possible." Ghidorah shook his head. "Marie left us, many upon many cycles ago. We have not seen her for an age or two."

I frowned. "But you said she rules over you. Do you mean like, in your hearts she is always with you or something?"

"No no, she still sends us messages through cockroaches and other small insects. Since we live outside the normal part of the labyrinth in our own little crawlways and tunnels, the only way to contact us is through telepathy or bug-mail, and telepathy can only be used at short

range." Ghidorah nodded profusely. I guess it made sense. Damn! And I was so close to finding someone who could get me answers.

"Well, surely you must have an idea where your God is located, correct?" I beckoned around the room and out towards the greater part of the labyrinth. "She must be somewhere, or she might be dead too."

The entire group of lizardmen let out a shrill warcry. "Anyone who kills Marie will face our full might! They will rue the day they were born!" I stared at the group of teeny monsters. I'm pretty sure I could kill all of them at once if I used that 'Push' spell I'd used before and they wouldn't know what hit them. I don't think they realized how insignificant they were.

"Well, if she is still alive, then I must find her. I must take my leave." I stood up straight instead of bending over at the back as I had been doing up to now. My back popped. Ahh, it felt good to stand normally once again.

King Ghidorah nodded. "Wait, before you go, we have a gift for you, as a friend of Marie." I nodded slowly. A gift huh? What could it be? Ghidorah let out a shrill scream towards the hole in the ceiling. "Bring out the feast!"

Feast? FOOD? My mouth watered at the thought. A stupid image of ice cream and cake found its way into my mind. There's no way they'd have that.

...They didn't. It was all chicken. A whole bunch of goddamn chicken.

Part 028:

"I will go with you." A lizardman from a small distance behind the king spoke. He was a head taller than the other lizards. Still tiny, but among them he was noticeably large. "I am Kar, the fearsome and great warrior. Among my people, I bear the blood of the Crocodiles from our distant ancestors."

The king nodded vigorously. "Kar is a mighty warrior, he has slain many foes with his powerful spear. None will protect you on your journey as Kar has to our kind." Several nearby lizards reached over and whacked Kar on the back. "Protect the fleshbag! Our protection goes with you!" With the special vision granted me by the Crown of Solomon, I noticed that his energy level was rising. His comrades must have given him some of their energy to infuse his own. They can do that? Good to know.

That was three hours ago. Kar now totters along beside us. I feel sick to my stomach though. I have eaten far too much chicken for far too long. I've been in this Labyrinth for almost three weeks now. Three weeks of nothing but chicken. I'd eat anything else at this point. I eyeball Kar. I wonder how he'd taste roasted? Considering his diet... probably like chicken.

Yet for some reason, Amelia and Kar love it. They devoured the chicken like it was the best food in the world. Amelia said something uncomfortable about how she wished it had a lot more blood in it, but I just pretended not to hear. This place is weird. Everything is weird.

Hoarhiim sighs in my mind. I realized neither he nor Blaarjiim had spoken during the entirety of the confrontation with the lizardmen. "That was lucky. We almost were killed."

Huh? Killed? "What do you mean?" I ask him. "You don't mean the lizardmen do you?" I glance over at Kar who was speaking with Amelia on the subject of being a great warrior, something he was intimately familiar with. She appeared to be bored by the conversation.

"Yes, the lizardmen. One small misstep and you could have gotten us killed." Hoarhiim quietly chided me.

"I lowered my voice so Kar couldn't pick up on my words. "They don't seem that scary. Aren't you being a little wimpy, for a deity Lord of Light?"

Hoarhiim glared in my mind. "You're still a naive child, despite the power you possess. You truly know nothing of this place. The Lizard King is one of the most powerful beings in this labyrinth. He's far above my own level, even with my power condensed like this. If you fought him as you are now, you would lose."

I stared at Hoarhiim blankly. "He's like a foot tall. How could he possibly be a threat to me?"

"Size matters not in this place." Hoarhiim mentally wagged his finger at me. "The moment you underestimate someone here, that is the moment you will die. Don't you know anything about the hierarchy here?"

I paused for a moment. Come to think of it, I didn't. I know there's lords and kings, but that's really all I know. "No, I'm still new to this whole thing."

Hoarhiim sighed again. He was doing that a lot lately. "Listen well. There is a strict hierarchy here, enforced for the last few millennia. First there are monsters, then ruling above those are lord-class monsters, such as me, and above us, there reside Dukes. Above Dukes there are Kings, and the final tier is Emperor, but there only exists three Emperors so that makes them a fairly rare monster. The one you could have enraged is a King class, and the King of Scales possesses many unknown abilities, since his people are reclusive. Furthermore, everyone of his same caliber or lower who has challenged him in fair combat died brutally, as did all of their companions. To top it off, he and his people eat the remains and clean up the battlefield so in the last few thousand years, nobody has had any idea what his abilities even are."

I swallow. This labyrinth is a scary place. I felt mighty before but with this knowledge, I'm dropped down a few pegs. That means most of the monsters I've seen so far, including the one strapped to my waist, were of the bottom two tiers. And I'm only the second tier with my own power as it is now. Except...

"Wait, Hoarhiim. What about Solomon's Crown? Combined with your power, does that make me still just of the Lord tier?"

Hoarhiim nodded. "Yes, and while my power is condensed thanks to my current form, you having a legendary item makes you an upper-tier Lord. You're certainly in the top ten, but don't get too cocky. There are thousands of Lords in this labyrinth. You're nothing special."

I feel crestfallen. Thousands, huh? I have a lot of competition. I wonder where Beelzebub falls in the rankings. He has to be number 1, right? I mean, he's a mythical demon spoken of in the bible. It's silly that he's even just Lord class.

But no matter. We must move on. "Hey, Amelia, Kar, are we ready to go?"

Kar nods vigorously. "Of course, great turtle! We are ready for anything you ask us to do!"

Amelia nods much less vigorously. "Sure, yeah, what he said. Just don't let me get dirty alright? I rather like this dress."

I smiled and nodded. Next stop: That big door at the end of the hallway. Time to get some answers.

Part 029: Error

Looking up that long hallway, I felt irritation. It was still a LONG walk back to the door. It took us half an hour last time. Even at a brisk jog, it was a quarter of an hour.

I was feeling antsy and didn't want to wait that long listening to Amelia and Kar jabber at each other about stupid stuff. So I got an idea in my head.

Raising my hand up and aiming my palm at my body, I tried something new.

"Speed."

I felt nothing. But, hopefully, it boosted my athletic ability, I tried running forward and noticed that Amelia seemed to be following my movement much more slowly, her eyes always lagging a half second behind me. Hm.

Remembering that time I had fought the shadow, I wondered to myself if I had actually slowed time, or if I had simply been moving so fast that my perception of time made the shadow appear to move slowly. Now that I thought about it, seeing Amelia having trouble following my movement, that seemed the likely scenario.

Looking further down the hallway far into the darkness towards the door at the end I currently couldn't see, I raised my palm up and pointed it at my body.

"Speed!"

Again, nothing felt different. Amelia appeared to be frozen, however. Her body was completely unmoving, the movement of the great lake of bodies deep below me was totally still. Yes, this must be the case and this explains what happened to me earlier.

I started to take a step forwards, and instantly an insane amount of pain washed over me, and I felt myself falling, the world spinning, as I blacked out.

I came to, and Amelia was hunched over me, my head in her lap. My entire body was in agony. Glancing over to my right, I saw Kar standing almost eye level to me. He really was short. To my left was the great door. What happened? Did I black out and Amelia carried me all the way here?

"Are you all right??" Amelia looked panicked. "What happened??"

I tried to shake my head but just trying to do so caused me a lot of pain. "I... I tried to speed myself up... and then I passed out... was it too much for my body?"

My head was swimming. Amelia's concern only grew deeper. "One second you were standing there, and the next you ran away! You ran so fast I almost didn't even see you move! You ran

towards the great door, and when we got here, your body was lying on the ground in a crumpled mess! You tell ME what happened!"

I couldn't move my head so I had her lift my head so that I could see the state of my body. It was bad. Bones stuck out of various areas. The skin was badly muddled. My nice tunic she had made me was covered in blood.

But I think I know what happened. I only *thought* my perception had increased with my body's speed. It had not. My body moved insanely fast, far too fast for me to comprehend. I must have raced down the corridor at a speed approaching the speed of sound and smashed into the Great Door. I'm lucky to be alive.

"You're lucky to be alive." said Hoarhiim, once again apparently reading my mind. "That was maybe your greatest display of stupidity yet. As I said before, you're one of the top ten lords in terms of power, but you have no idea how to use any of it so even one of the weakest ones would surely defeat you in combat. And now..."

My body was badly broken. There was no way to heal myself. I couldn't move either of my hands at all, and I could feel my life ebbing away. "Ah... this is it... this is the end..."

I looked up into Amelia's eyes. I don't know why, but I had hoped she'd be crying. Maybe she'd miss me or something. That did not appear to be the case. She certainly looked a little worried, but also a little unconcerned. It made sense I guess, I was just a momentary amusement for her, a small distraction from the boredom of this hell.

"Are you an idiot?" she asked me this flatly. I suddenly felt stupid but didn't know why.

"I mean... maybe?" I don't know why she asked me that.

Raising her hand in the air, she drew some imaginary symbols. I could suddenly feel my strength returning. My bones slowly (But painfully) set themselves back together. My skin mended itself, the crumpled bloody mess that I was slowly became whole again.

An hour later, much longer than it would have taken if I had just patiently walked to the end, my body was whole again. She had even had the foresight to use some cleaning magic to purify my clothes.

"I... didn't know you could use healing magic too..." I eyed Blaarjiim. I guess even the Lord of Darkness wouldn't forgo such useful magic.

"Don't look at Blaarjiim! He had nothing to do with it!" Amelia stood up and crossed her arms smugly. "It was all me! Underestimate the Lord of Flies at your own peril!"

I smiled. "Well, ah, thank you. This was all my fault."

"No kidding." Said Blaarjiim, rolling his eyes. "This could have been hilarious if you'd just had the decency to smash into the wall in front of me. I didn't even get to see anything funny."

That guy, always taking a perverse interest in my suffering.

We finally turned around and examined the door. I decided to try something as a joke.

" *Mellon.* "

I spoke a single word at the door. Nothing happened. Damn, and here I had hoped we wouldn't have to force our way in.

Steeling my body against the door, I gave a mighty push. It's time to solve this mystery.

Part 030: Throne

I really gave it my all.

Pushing with all my might, I shoved and pushed and shoved and pushed. I even used a moderate "Power" spell to try and boost my strength. It didn't work. I wanted to try and do a full forced "POWER!" but I also didn't want to accidentally kill myself. Have to learn my limits before I go doing things like that. I still have no idea how it all works.

"This isn't working." I draw back and feel sweat pouring down my body. It's hot in here. I never really noticed it before, but the ambient heat from the warm floor can get noticeably hot when you work up a sweat. "Damn. I need much more strength."

This door is at least a hundred times heavier than the Golden Door that led to Solomon's Crown. I'm not even sure if *Push* at full power would slightly move it. Whoever built this door here, they did not ever want it open.

Kar stared at the great door. "Perhaps I could do it."

I looked down at the tiny little reptile and stifled a laugh. "Uh, I mean, you're free to try."

Kar looked up at me, his face completely flat, no form of emotion visible. "Do you doubt that I can do it?"

I shook my head. "No, no! Of course not! You're a big- I mean a strong crocodile! I'm sure you can, uh, at least do something to that door!"

Kar turned away from me. "I am the mightiest warrior among my people, strong enough that even the King himself respects me. I know what respect feels like, and yet you give none to me. I must rectify this."

Something astounding happened. I never expected to see this. Of all the things I could imagine, this was the most shocking. Kar *grew*.

He grew BIG too. He started shifting his size slowly, but as I watched he got bigger and bigger until he soon passed even my 5'10" height and surged upwards to a grand finale of... ten feet??? He was one tall son of a bitch.

He looked down at me, with his massive, hulking monstrous body. "Well then, little turtle. Who is the small one now?"

My mouth was apparently gaping open. I suddenly remembered that it would be rude to stare so I quickly averted my gaze from his eyes. "I am..." I mumbled. "I apologize for my lack of respect."

"Good." I could almost feel a reptilian grin forming on the face above me, as I looked at my shuffling feet. "Now then, I want you to strengthen me with your power."

I jerked my head up. "Me? You want my power?"

"Yes. I lack a sufficient supply of spiritual energy and I also lack the ability to tap into the Thought Energy. I lack magical abilities, but I make up for it with superior might!". He pounded his chest and it made a loud CRACK. "Do it! Give me power!"

To be honest, I was scared to give this towering behemoth even more power than he already had, but I was too scared to refuse him, so I did.

Aiming my hand at him, I chanted.

" Power! "

A moment passed. I looked up from his chest to his face. He seemed annoyed. "Was that it? That's all you can give? I barely felt it."

I started to protest, but hey, fuck it. If he wants my full power, I'll let him have it. He'll learn his lesson.

"POOOWERRRR!!!!!"

I felt my energy levels decrease substantially. To make an estimate, my bellowing scream must have lowered my energy by about half. That means I could do that twice in a row, at most, before I was completely exhausted.

However, I was stunned. Kar looked completely untouched. He flexed his muscles. "Hm. It's not much, but it will have to do. Rather disappointing."

This is the difference between my body and his. If I put that much power into myself, I'd probably overload my heart. To him, it was like the breeze under a butterfly's wings. I am still far too weak.

Kar turned to the door. Placing both his hands on it, he turned his head back to look at me.

"Little turtle, you had better step back."

Part 031:

"Can they all do that?"

I spoke to Hoarhiim. Amelia and I were standing back quite a ways from the door, as Kar was about to heave it open with his brutal power.

"Can who do what?" Hoarhiim didn't catch the gist of what I was asking.

"The lizardmen. Can they all grow taller like that at will?" I pointed at Kar. "He's humongous. It doesn't seem physically possible to grow that big from such a small body."

"It's a defense mechanism." Blaarjiim interjected. "All lizardmen can do it, they've been doing it for thousands of years. They made their bodies smaller through magic so that they could live inside much smaller places. They dig into the walls of the Labyrinth and evade the usual routes that the hallways take. Because of this, they are the most reclusive denizens of this place."

Hoarhiim nodded. "Lizardmen also gained the ability to shift between their forms at will. Each form has its own fighting benefits. When they are small, they move extremely fast, and are very hard to hit with an attack. But when they are big, they become much stronger and more resistant to attacks."

I nodded. "I underestimated them. I will try not to do that to any other resident of this Hell ever again."

Kar pushed on the door, digging his feet into the ground. The door shifted noticeably. My heart leaped for joy but then settled back down. While I was excited to see what was in that room, I also worried about it. If there was something terrifying in there that was being sealed for a reason, perhaps I shouldn't let it out.

I glanced downwards, at the souls of the humans floating in the river of acid and fire. This was Hell. It had to be. I must have died in that cryopod, and everything I'm experiencing now will eventually lead to my soul being reaped. I will eventually end up down there with them as well. Perhaps whatever is behind this door is the final judgement for me. Perhaps this is my own Pandora's Box that I am opening up.

The air began shaking. I was confused for a second, then I looked up. Kar was heaving on the door with all his might. His mouth was open, like he was screaming, but I could hear nothing. I could feel the air vibrating, however. A quick glance at Amelia made me realize she was wincing

in noticeable pain. "Amelia? Are you okay?" I tried to speak but the words did not come out. Or rather they did, but whatever was making the air vibrate, it was seemingly drowning me out.

Using the intuition gained from Solomon's Crown, I deduced that Kar was screaming a warcry to bolster his strength, and the sound was at an insanely high frequency that I couldn't even hear. I could only vaguely sense it through the vibrations all around me.

Kar heaved with all his might, suddenly, once the outer edge of the right door that he was pressing on cleared the inner edge of the left door, the door swung open and he fell forwards and collapsed on the ground. Amelia and I raced up behind him, and suddenly a chill went down my spine.

This was a mistake. This was a big mistake.

Part 032: Chosen

I've had many regrets in my life.

For example, that time I tried eating a PB&J without the J, that time I ignored an old man who needed help crossing the road, that time I decided my entire life was worth giving up to get inside a cryopod...

But most of them pale compared to the regret I feel over opening that door.

An army of monsters. An absolute metric fuckton of monsters. I remember seeing rock concerts and images of battlefields of war, and I never saw one that had as many beings as what I now looked at.

Skeletons, werebears, dark horseman, bone mages, goblins, orcs, dark elves, gryphons, even a few small lesser drakes, every type of monster I could think of was here. There had to be a million monsters or more. They stretch on and on in this very well lit mega-room for probably miles back, as the room fanned outwards and got bigger and bigger the further it went back. I could not see the back wall, if such a thing existed.

I had no words for what I saw. They all stared at me unblinkingly, as if to ask "Who dares enter our sacred land?"

Yes, unblinkingly, that is the word. I mean, the skeletons don't have the ability to blink, but the other monsters weren't blinking either. I found myself in a cold sweat. What the hell was going on. A *very* quick glance at Kar showed no look of concern whatsoever. *Gwahahaha I'll just defeat them all for I am the mightiest!* I bet that's what was going through his head.

However, Amelia also looked unconcerned. And then I realized, all the monsters weren't moving. At first, I thought they were fucking statues again, but they were not. They were simply... waiting for something.

"Are you the chosen one?"

A voice boomed from the back of the room. I could not detect where it came from.

"I... I don't know!" I yelled this in the general direction of the voice that I had heard.

"Only the chosen one may enter."

The voice sounded like it was accusing me of something. It was a very loud voice, like the sound of a not-too-distant erupting volcano.

"And how would I know if I am the chosen one?" I yelled this at the source of the voice.

From the back of the hall, I saw thousands of the monsters in that area suddenly shifting over to the sides of the room. They continued shifting, and the seeming tidal wave of movement made its way forward. That voice was a truly terrifying one. The power contained in it defied explanation. Whatever it was, I did not want to anger it. *I reaaaally did not want to anger it.*

Once the tidal wave of movement opened up to the front, I was mystified to see a beautiful mermaid, someone gliding across the ground with her tail. Six massive wings sprouted out of her body. Her body had no scales on it, it was simply smooth, soft skin. But her voice, it was decidedly masculine, and very terrifying at this close range.

"If you do not know, you will be tested."

I wondered quietly to myself how a mermaid could command this much awe and respect from all the monsters around her. Of course, given what I had witnessed with Kar, I did not wish to underestimate her at all. Plus, Amelia's mouth was agape.

Amelia stuttered to life and asked a simple, one word question. "B-B-Bahamut?!"

My eyes must have bulged open. I thought Bahamut was like, a great dragon, or some kind of serpent. Not... a mermaid? No. Wait. I had it wrong. She was no mermaid, she was a *Siren*. This was evident by the mouth full of teeth resembling that of a great white shark.

"If you fail the test, I will strike all of you down."

I figured this was a stupid question, but I had to ask anyway. "Can we just, not take the test, and um... quietly leave?"

In my mind, Blaarjiim and Hoarhiim both facepalmed. Wow guys, thanks for the support.

"Once you enter, only if you are Chosen may you leave."

Part 033: The Test Part 1

I winced. This loud voice was becoming unbearable. Especially at such a close range. "Oh Great Bahamut..." I said this as reverently as I could muster. "Before I take this test, might you honor me with a small request? Just a trifle?"

Bahamut looked amused.

"An army of hell, and a God stands here, yet you would make a request of me!"

I winced more visibly. "Yes, ah, I would just like to ask if you could possibly, ah, tone down your voice. I am far too weak of a being to withstand your incredible power!"

Good move me. Make the request into a compliment. Bitches love it when you do shit like that.

The next thing I heard, I did not actually hear. It was in my head. Bahamut communicated with me telepathically, in a much deeper way than Blaarjiim and Hoarhiim had done so up to this point. The voice was everywhere inside my head.

"As you wish. It is true that my power can be too daunting for any but a Duke or higher so I shall grant your request. But only this one."

"Ah! Thank you, oh great Bahamut! Your, uh, generosity truly knows no limits!" Hell yeah, slick as fuck. I'm laying it on and she's falling for my charms.

"Idiot." whispered Amelia off in the distance away from me. Maybe I was getting too full of myself.

"Now begins the test. It will consist of three trials. To be recognized as the chosen one, you must pass all three of them. Once you have done so, you will be allowed to leave. Since I do not anticipate that happening, make sure you say your last prayers first." Bahamut smirked at me, as she glided away, the sea of minions parting the way in front of her. That bitch, I'll show her who's boss.

My two companions and I followed Bahamut. We arrived within a minute at a massive, raised platform. It was square, about a football field wide in both directions. I'd never seen such a massive flat platform. Raised up a hundred feet in the air, it offered quite the view. I looked around as we climbed the stairs up the platform. I was wrong. There were far more than a million monsters here. I dare say I grossly underestimated the number. Far in the distance, I spotted a massive town, stretching on for the foreseeable distance.

"Incredible." whispered Amelia, as we walked up the steps. I understood where she was coming from. What baffled me however, was the fact that we hadn't seen this platform at all until we were practically on top of it. Did it rise out of the ground when I wasn't paying attention? Maybe there was magical cloaking technology involved.

Arriving at the top, I was stunned. I could still, even this high up, see no end to the monsters. They flowed seemingly forever. They blotted out my view of the river of fire and acid below. Where the hell did all these monsters come from? Was this the factory where nightmares were made?

Arriving at the exact center of the platform, the three of us turned to face Bahamut. Bahamut held up her hand. On it were three rings. *"I have never once had anyone pass all three of these tests. In fact, nobody who has entered my domain has ever passed even the first one. I am sorry in advance if your death comes too swiftly for you to process."*

Bahamut indicated the three rings on her hand. *"These three rings are Legendary class items. For each test you pass, if that is even possible, you may pick one ring and keep it for yourself. It will be bound to you forever."*

Amelia gasped audibly. "Three legendary items? Oh wow! Those must be incredibly valuable!"

"Indeed. Back before I killed the Army of Akkad, I had renown for simply possessing these three rings." Bahamut indicated the three rings one by one. *"I will only tell you that each ring once belonged to a mighty Pharaoh from the past. Each one will grant you immeasurable power, but together, you will unlock something inside yourself that you never knew existed."* I nodded vigorously. This was exciting. I'm probably about to die, but damn if this wasn't worth it, just to see what the power of those rings was.

"And." Bahamut stared directly into my eyes. *"If, by some stroke of luck, you should manage to pass all three challenges, I will voluntarily bow to your will and become your loyal servant, until one of us dies."*

The crowd around us, the vast unending throng, erupted into cheers and whoops. A great warcry went out, feet began marching in place and stomping in unison. The energy in the place was palpable.

"By the gods, they sound excited." Shit, I could have the power of a living God in my hands, if I could just pass some challenges. It was probably impossible, but this deal was getting better every minute.

"Of course they're excited." Bahamut smiled a gracious, loving smile. *"All of them are people that have challenged me for the right to own these rings. All of them failed, and were*

cursed into their current forms."

Holy. Shit.

Part 034: The Test Part 2

I felt numb. All these poor unfortunate souls had challenged Bahamut... and lost. The gravity of the situation was sinking in on me.

However, something else bothered me too. She had said that her three rings belonged to Pharaohs. Egyptian Pharaohs? Like, from Earth? Then, was this actually, somehow, Earth a hundred million years in the future? Was this a different dimension? Was this place a literal hell for me as I had died inside my cryopod? What did it all mean?

Amelia had stars in her eyes. I remembered that back in the El Dorado room, she had strongly eyeballed all the treasure there. It would seem that she likes shiny things. Her eyes were glued to the rings on Bahamut's hand.

"For the first test..." Bahamut pointed at me. "You must answer a riddle. This riddle has never been answered. Not throughout all of human or demonic history. Failure to answer correctly will result in instant death."

I blinked. A riddle? "Are my companions allowed to help me?"

Bahamut nodded. *"Yes, they may speak freely. Nothing they say will be considered an answer. However, you may not speak once I have asked the question. If you do, anything you say will be considered the answer. Do not speak unless you have an answer in mind."*

I nodded vigorously. This was intense. My life rode on the answer to this riddle. And then I had two more terrifying tests to undertake after this one. Looking out over the river of monsters, it really hit me in the chest. Millions have tried to pass these tests, and none have even gotten past the first riddle. That means this riddle is so complex that it may be unguessable.

Bahamut reached inside her cloak she had wrapped around her body, and pulled out an hourglass filled with sand. *"You will have from the moment I finish speaking the riddle, to the moment this sand runs out, 5 minutes in total, to give your answer. If you do not start speaking your answer before the sand runs out, you and your companion's lives will be forfeit. Do you understand?"*

I glanced over at Amelia. Her starry eyes were gone, and she seemed to be trembling in fear. It must have sunk into her mind the gravity of this situation. This was no simple riddle, if we failed, we would be enslaved monsters forever.

I nodded slowly. "Yes, great Bahamut. I understand the conditions for this test."

Bahamut nodded back. " *Good. Then we will begin.* "

Bahamut cleared her throat with a great thunderous crash, though it hardly seemed needed, given she was communicating telepathically.

Then I realized, she was not going to speak telepathically.

"What walks on four legs in the morning, two legs in the afternoon, three legs in the evening, and no legs at night?"

Part 035: The Test Part 3

Bahamut smiled. This was it. The moment she had been waiting for. It had been a long time since some fool had challenged her domain.

She issued her riddle. The Child of Gaia was instantly rendered speechless. She stifled her smile, as it was not polite to mock someone before they gave their terrible answer. The three of them were as good as hers. She drifted off in thought, remembering what led her to choose that riddle.

* * *

Long ago, when she was just a young child, living as a slave in Egypt, she had stumbled on the Sphinx. The Sphinx was a mighty looking creature, with the body of a cougar, the wings of an eagle, and the head of a great maned lion.

She had been completely awestruck at the sight of the monster in front of her. Having run away from the Egyptian slavers, she had stumbled upon it purely by accident.

The Sphinx was a timeless monster. Having existed since before the dawn of man, it had knowledge no human could comprehend. It was aging however, and tired of the riddles it had plagued many a traveler with.

Looking down at its feet, the Sphinx spotted a small human child. A little girl. the child was petrified with terror. The child would hardly be a worthwhile snack. She certainly lacked the cognitive abilities to solve his riddle. In short, she was nothing to him at all.

"Begone, little one. I will not harm a defenseless creature. It is unsavory." The Sphinx pawed her away. The child made a mad scramble to hide behind a rock, still staring at him in terror.

Hmm? She did not run from me? She is hiding, but yet seems to be curious.

The sphinx thought about his life. Proud and aged like wine, at its peak the Sphinx had tested the mettle of many adventurers. Any who passed his test were given incredible wealth, power, and influence, at the cost of their memory of the test being wiped. Only one had ever succeeded, and that was Pharaoh Khafre. Originally just a lower classed noble among the house of Egypt, he had managed to answer the Sphinx's riddle. The Sphinx, shocked that any human could guess the answer to his clever wordplay, rewarded the man, first by killing off his direct opponents to the throne's line, and then by giving him favor among the other lands. Khafre never forgot the power the Sphinx gave him, and built a massive monument in his honor.

But that was... many years ago. Khafre was long dead. The Sphinx thought bitterly that now that his riddle was answered, even though the answer had never gotten out, if others in the future answered it, it just wouldn't have the same meaning.

He looked down at the little child hiding behind a rock. "Tell me child, what is your name?"

* * *

Bahamut smiled. The Sphinx gave her the knowledge of his riddle, and part of his monstrous power. She had taken over for him, spreading the power of the riddle among the lands. Aside from Pharaoh Khafre, no person had ever successfully answered it, certainly not once she had gained it.

She had amassed an army worthy of a god, legendary items that granted her true godlike powers, and worship devoted to her as a god. There were none in this world of death and decay like Khafre. There were none that could hope to answer her riddle, certainly not within 5 minutes.

Looking back down, her smile disappeared. The Child of Gaia seemed wholly unconcerned. The little girl beside the Child was in a panic. But the Child seemed bored.

"Man."

Bahamut's expression hardened.

What.

Part 036: The Test Part 4

I was completely speechless. My mouth gaped open.

I stared at Bahamut numbly. You're kidding. This was the riddle? This was the riddle that had killed millions of warriors, adventurers, and kings? This stupid fucking riddle? Everyone knows the answer to this riddle. It's so easy. I remember accidentally reading it on a Facebook post from one of my few friends a couple years ago. Well, a couple years before I went in the cryotube.

I couldn't believe it. No, it just simply could not be that easy. Everyone knows the answer to this stupid riddle. I looked around at the throng of monsters gathered around the arena. *All of these monsters were men who failed to guess the answer to this riddle.*

I look over at Kar. His head was bowed. When I looked at him, he shook his head. He had no idea what the answer was, and didn't even want to guess.

Then I looked at Amelia. She was shaking, visibly. She seemed terrified. I heard her whispering something under her breath. " *Pleasedon'tkillmeohgodwe'regoingtodieIdon'tknowtheanswerohgodpleaseblessmysoul...* " I almost said some words of comfort but then I realized that would count as an answer.

I looked back at Bahamut. The smug bitch, she was staring up at the sky, lost in daydream land. She thinks she has this in the bag. Fucking cunt. I'm still baffled. It can't actually be this easy.

Think, Me. Is there another possible answer? Could it really just be the Sphinx's riddle? Why is a Siren asking the riddle anyway? Were the old legends wrong? If they were wrong about it being the Sphinx, they could possibly be wrong about the answer as well.

* * *

No, my answer was correct. It really was that easy. And that smug bitch is looking at me again. Look at her, she thinks she's already won.

I glance at the hourglass sitting on the table. A shockingly small amount of time has passed since she set it there. Maybe 15 seconds. I can't believe it's this easy.

I look back at her. Her face, which once had a grin, is suddenly no longer smiling. She seems to know my answer is coming. Oh well, here goes nothing.

"Man."

Her face freezes, a look of cold terror washes over it. I hear her voice in my mind. " *What.* " It wasn't a question, she was visibly stunned. That's right, you bitch, I know the answer. You'll regret taking on the Child of Gaia.

"When man is born, he walks on four legs. As he grows older, he walks on two. When he becomes elderly, he walks on three, with a cane being his third. Finally, when he dies, he no longer walks at all."

Bahamut staggers back. The shock is hitting her like a freight train.

"HOW?! HOW DID YOU KNOW THE ANSWER?!"

Her voice booms out loudly, making me wince. Amelia turns and gazes at me in awe, staring past my face and at the Crown of Solomon. "Oh my god... that truly is a legendary treasure!"

Suddenly Bahamut straightens her stance out and staggers back into a mostly normal position befitting a god. " *What? A legendary treasure? Wait... it can't be.* "

She lunges forwards and grabs at the crown on my head. Unfortunately for her, it will not come off unless I take it off myself. After letting her try for a solid five seconds, I swat her hand away.

" *Insolent-* " she backs away. " *Y-you cheated! You used the Crown of Solomon! You used the infinite wisdom of the king preferred by the highest God! You could never have guessed without it!* "

She suddenly regained her composure. " *Yes, yes of course, without the Crown of Solomon, you would have been in my grasp. Damn you!* "

She paces back and forth for a full minute, cursing many obscenities under her breath, before I politely, and loudly clear my throat.

"AHEM! Bahamut, I believe we had a deal. And you never said I couldn't wear the crown for the test, so that was your own fault." I smile. It's alright if she thinks it was the Crown that gave me the answer. In truth I would have known it before she answered even without the Crown, but she didn't have to know that.

She had seemed to regain her composure. She probably figured that since it was the Crown that knew the answer, and not me personally (wrong) then it didn't have to count and hurt her pride.

"Well, truthfully, the Crown told me everything, but I still get to take one of your rings."

She grimaced, an ugly expression for such a lovely face. The grimace revealed her incredibly numerous and sharp teeth.

" *Very well, I will not sully this moment by doing anything dishonorable. You may choose one ring.* " She held up her hand towards me and pointed at each finger individually. " *The first, the second, or the third?* "

I pondered it. I still had no idea what any of the rings even *did*. She simply said that they would grant me godlike powers.

Shrugging, I pick one at random. "Eeny meeny miney moe..." she looks confused, like she thought I was casting a spell on her hand. Oh well, fuck what she thinks.

Pointing at the second ring I speak to her. "The second one, the middle one. I'll take it."

She looks absolutely defeated. " *Very well... he is yours.* "

He? He who? I reach my hand out to accept the ring from her. She places it in my hand, and before I put it on my finger, I notice there's writing on it. Thanks to the Crown, I easily deduce that it's Egyptian. But the word on it is actually a name.

Gabriel.

Part 037: Gabriel

It couldn't be just any ordinary name. Gabriel. Only one name of significance immediately leaped to mind. It *could* be someone else but... only one way to know.

I slipped the ring on my finger. Suddenly everything went white. My ears rang like a bomb had gone off next to my head. My temples pounded. My body felt as if it were falling. Endlessly, falling into a great abyss, made of pure white. The world around me rapidly melted away as I fell. I flailed my arms, but realized they weren't moving. My head swam.

Inside that blinding light a voice spoke to me.

" Are you my new master? "

As I fell, a massive being, the size of... of a planet! Or bigger! He appeared. He dwarfed the horizon. The only thing I could see other than whiteness was him. He had silver armor on. A massive full helm sat atop his head. Unbelievably wide wings sprouted from his back. From the top of one wing to another, it must have been the span of an entire solar system. How my eyes could even comprehend something of this size failed me. My imagination was lost on the size of this being.

In his left hand, he held a massive shield, with a holy cross emblazoned on the front. In his right hand, a Bible was held. Instead of the words "Holy Bible" however, there were different words written on the front.

Yea, though I walk through the valley of the shadow of death

I will fear no evil - for thou art with me

The LORD is my strength and my shield

My heart trusts in Him, and through him I am saved.

The archangel has long, flowing golden hair. It goes from his head all the way down to his feet, or at least I assume it does. I cannot see his feet, so vast is his body.

I have been made to feel tiny and insignificant before. But never like this. This being that is in front of me, it is unlike any that I have ever seen. Without a doubt, I am bearing witness to a living god, or at least, a lesser god.

His master? Get real. I have no power over this being.

Again he asks the question.

" Are you my new master? "

I look deep into his eyes. His eyes are timeless. He knows all and sees all. He is an existence far above the whole of humanity and demonkind alike.

"No. I cannot be your master. You only have one master, and He is the one who rules on high."

The Archangel Gabriel does not speak. For many minutes, hours, an eternity. It seems forever that he neglects to respond.

* * *

Finally, he seems to change his mind. Raising his voice to a level that dwarfs even the loudest volume that Bahamut had reached, he bellows in a universe-shattering volume:

"Well done! You have passed the first test! I have chosen you!"

Part 038: Hero

I continued falling. I fell for a very long time.

As I fell, I thought of many things. I don't know why I was brought here. I don't know what made me end up in this hellish world. But I knew it wasn't right. This world itself... was not right.

It's been a short time since I arrived, but I have been gaining power and abilities quickly. I never felt satisfied by it though. I do not desire power, I do not desire wealth. Despite my first inclinations, I don't even want to rule this place or anything silly like that.

But when I see that river of souls flowing beneath me, I realize that there is one thing I could do. I could release the denizens trapped in this place. I could do something to alleviate their eternal suffering.

But for right now, I just don't know what.

* * *

As I fall, I gradually pick up speed. The whiteness around me starts to fade and my body turns in flight as the ground rushes towards me. Below me sits a familiar room, lost for an eternity in my mind. Yes, that's right, I remember now. I was facing Bahamut here. She had challenged me, and I defeated her with my own knowledge.

As I fell, I realized I was falling towards my own body. I was still standing in the original spot. One hand was slipping that ring on my finger, that ring that had taken me to Gabriel.

Suddenly, I was back to reality.

I jerked my head up with a start. I felt very disoriented, Around me, everything was as it looked before. "Huh? Am I back?"

It was a stupid question. Of course I was back. But I had been gone so long that I had forgotten what reality felt like. Amelia was looking up at me eagerly, then her face turned to disappointment.

"Did anything happen? Come on, you can tell me! I'll keep it a secret!" She jumped up and down excitedly.

"Ah... how long... have I been standing here with this ring on my finger?" I looked around. I couldn't tell at all.

"I don't know, like, 5 seconds? Do you feel stronger or anything??" She kept looking at the ring and back up to my face and back down to the ring again while bounding on her toes lightly.

"Well?? Did that ring do anything legendary?"

So it would appear that it had all happened in the blink of an eye. In the span of only a second or two, I had gone to a heavenly place, spoken with a Supreme Deity, and then returned, but to me it had felt like a few eons. If time flies when you are having fun, then does time crawl when doing something monumental?

I turned back to Bahamut. She was staring at the ground. A look of great sadness on her face. When she realized I was looking at her, she raised her head and stared, not at me, but at the ring on my finger. She spoke now, far more quietly than before, and not in my mind either.

"So... you've returned. Since you aren't dead... you must have passed."

I nodded. "He must have been the Archangel Gabriel. The one spoken of in the book of Daniel. What is the significance of this ring?"

She finally smiled again, though it was a faint, listless smile. "That is for you to find out. When I had put the ring on, an eternity ago... I failed his test. He never spoke to me again. But in the time that I knew of him... it was ecstasy."

Bahamut slumped to the floor in defeat and stared at the ground listlessly.

"There's no more point continuing. You must truly be a fearsome hero of myth. You not only guessed the answer to a riddle that has vexed champions and kings, you did so effortlessly, and then you passed Gabriel's test. There's no point in going on with the other two tests."

I was taken aback. After all that big deal she had made, she was going to just cancel the tests? "You're pathetic." I spat this at her and she jerked her head up angrily. "Giving up after a single failing. If you were truly a god, you should be filled with shame. What I witnessed inside the ring was truly a magnificent specter. Compared to the Archangel, you are weak. You are pitiful."

An idea formed in my head. Turning around suddenly, I began to speak to the throng of people.

"Repent ye therefore, and be converted, that your sins may be blotted out, when the times of refreshing shall come from the presence of the Lord "

Saying this, a powerful image appeared above me. A great phantom. Gabriel himself, in a far smaller, yet still terrifyingly awesome form, appeared. He was hundreds of feet tall, reaching up to the ceiling I could not see above me. He spoke now.

" Ye who have summoned me, I have come to bring forth a cleansing, a removal of the sins of those who were deceived by the one called Satan and the Devil. Repent, those who fell to greed and envy, and ye shall be made whole again. "

The crowd of people became breathlessly still as they gazed at the Archangel in wonder. Falling to their knees, they began bowing and praying, begging for their sins to be cleansed.

One by one, they started changing, slowly at first, and then faster and faster until rapidly, like a reversed plague, they became human again, the entire throng of people around me regaining their original forms. Tears were shed, a people once broken, started to become whole.

They then began to chant, this aimed at me.

"All hail the HERO, the one sent from on high!"

Over and over, they chanted. A mighty battlecry. I turned around and looked back at Bahamut. She was visibly stunned.

This was it. I now knew why I was sent here. I had a purpose.

"Get up. Your time to lie down is long gone."

Part 039: Awakening

I pointed my finger at Bahamut.

"I have judged you and found you lacking. You posed as a god, when really you were a devil. You deceived men for your own personal gain. You ruined lives, you ruined countries, you helped bring ruin to the entire world, and in the end you were just a coward."

I felt disgust, just looking at this creature. She was a fraud. She had no real power. All her power came from those rings on her finger, and at least in the case of Gabriel, she hadn't even succeeded in using that power.

I could feel, inside my body, that my own power had risen exponentially. I could visually see the spiritual energy of every person in the room thanks to the power of Solomon's crown. Bahamut certainly had an imposing presence, but her actual spiritual energy was lackluster. Perhaps comparable to me when I had first touched Hoarhiim.

As for me, ever since Gabriel accepted me, I had increased my power tenfold. Rivers of spiritual energy poured off my body invisibly and dissipated when it hit the ground. And, most notably, the color of my energy was white. Pure white. Bahamut's energy was red, indicating bloodlust and blood shed. She was a killer.

But then I noticed something... odd. I happened to glance at Amelia, with my newly awakened vision. She too had a spiritual energy color. It was black, pure unending pitch black. A complete void of any color. And, I came to realize, the energy pouring out of her own body vastly dwarfed mine. It raged out of her body. She was a tiny little girl with a cute smile, but that smile hid a terrifying power.

And if she was a servant of the dark... and I was a servant of the light... would we have to fight someday? I turned away. That would have to wait until the unforeseeable future.

Bahamut sneered at me. "Coward?! Well, look at you. A child started playing with a new toy that got a little cocky. Isn't that... cute." She tried to sound menacing, but without her booming voice granted by stealing what little she could of Gabriel's essence, she sounded weak and minuscule.

I lowered my hand and stopped pointing at her. "We will continue where we left off."

Part 040:

Damn! It had all changed so fast.

First, I was gloating over an easy victory. Then that brat, that little child... somehow managed to defeat my riddle and even solve the condition to awaken Gabriel. You were only granted one chance and if you failed you could never retry.

I had failed, and in return that brat had succeeded. In the instant the ring was put on, I perceived an incredible shift in his power. He must have awakened Gabriel... DAMN! When I failed, I only evaded death because I was already wearing Michael's ring and that granted me protection. That child was truly lucky, for he would have surely been crushed if he failed.

I gnashed my teeth together.

Okay. It's fine if the Child won. I... I can live with this. I still had Raphael and Michael. Gabriel had never given me his power, but Raphael and Michael had.

Gabriel: The Mighty King

Raphael: The Wisdom King

Michael: The Divine King

Each of these archangels had been instrumental to my rise. Without them, I could not have forced an honorable challenge against so many. They would surely have simply left, but once a challenge is issued, the three rings guarantee neither participant can leave until the challenge is completed.

But now I only have two of those rings. My ability to force the challenge is over. The Child of Gaia can leave whenever he wishes.

* * *

Wait. The Child does not yet know this. I still may have a chance to regain Gabriel, assuming the child continues the challenges and I win. It's not hopeless yet.

The child and I exchanged words. Even as he stunned me by using the power of Gabriel to free my warriors from my grasp, still... I held on to hope. Even as he issued a declaration of competition from me, I kept my smile buried inside. This child was weaker than he thought.

The throng of citizens I once considered my own people chanted a warcry. "Hero" they called him. No, he was just a child. A Hero would not allow the monster a chance to consolidate its power. His desire for glory and fame would be his undoing. He was no hero, he was simply a greedy child who wanted mommy's attention.

Well, I say... good for you. You got it.

I rose up to my full height, twelve feet tall. I towered over the child and even his rather tall companion.

"Prepare yourself. I will grant you no mercy."

Part 041:

"Well. That was lame."

Amelia laid on her stomach on the bed, twiddling a piece of fabric with her fingers.

"Like, she hardly even put up a fight. Was she really that strong in the first place?" Amelia was greatly disappointed. She blew a piece of hair up and away from her face as it fell in front of her eye.

I shrugged. "There were many great leaders, at least in my human history, who relied more on trickery or deceit rather than raw power to achieve their goals. Bahamut was just... one of those kinds of beings."

I chewed on the meat. I'm just glad it wasn't any more fucking chicken. I'm so tired of chicken.

"I have to say, Roasted Bahamut is actually quite good. A solid texture. Soft enough to eat without silverware, but tough enough to get a real workout for my mouth." Kar mumbled as he stuffed his face. Turns out she tasted a lot like fish.

We were inside the great palace she had created an eon ago. Servants and people greatly thankful for freeing them were bringing us anything we asked for. I was a veritable king at the moment.

As I chewed on a cooked piece of Bahamut, I considered how quickly it had all ended. Thanks to Solomon's Crown, I was able to perceive that some invisible condition had been released when I took the ring, and I no longer had to accept her tests.

She was so weak. And surprisingly stupid. She tried badly to goad me into accepting another challenge, I simply pretended to accept, and then when I got tired of her stalling, I destroyed her in a flash.

Actually, I had the weird feeling that there weren't three challenges in the first place. There was only one challenge, the riddle. The other two were a ruse to con adventurers into challenging her for her rings.

But why? Thanks to the power of the rings, all she had to do was issue the challenge herself. It was considered a spiritually binding contract. Why did she need the adventurers to issue a challenge?

My head hurt. It doesn't matter anyway. Now she's dead and we're all devouring her non-chicken flesh greedily. I of course stuck to the fish-like tail, as did Amelia. The more... human

looking parts... we left those to Kar. He's a crocodile, so to him meat is just meat.

I twiddled the two rings in my finger. *Michael* and *Raphael*. I hadn't put them on yet. I'm not sure if I was ready for another episode of what happened with Gabriel. Soon though, I will. For now, I have a new mission.

Amelia. She is dangerous. She seems sweet and innocent, but I've witnessed her darker side on more than a few occasions. And thanks to my recent merging with Gabriel, as well as the further enhanced abilities of the Crown, I have noticed many key things.

[if!supportLists]1. Her power far exceeds mine. I have not yet witnessed any other demons with my new vision, but hers is definitely far above me.

[if!supportLists]2. Her aura is a demonic black. I saw auras of many other people at this place. Nobody else is black, or any shade similar. I don't know if this is unique to her or if all creepy little demon girls are like this.

[if!supportLists]3. I'm fairly certain of why her power is so extreme. Beelzebub called her "The Lord of Flies". She also has Blaarjiim's power inside her. That means she has the combined power of two demon lords. Wouldn't that make her... the strongest demon lord? Maybe even a Duke? I don't have enough data on other Lords so I just can't accurately tell how strong she is in the rankings.

Amelia. Who is she? Where does she come from? I must find out.

Part 042:

A bolt of lightning flew past my head. It missed me by inches.

" **Barrier!** " I yelled this and a magic barrier surrounded Amelia, who was taking the fight head-on. Just in the nick of time too, as a fireball glanced off and melted into the scorched earth, dissipating harmlessly.

Aiming at my body, I yelled again. " **Rock!** ", instantly my body gained a hardened earthen armor. This would nullify electricity for sure. As the Crown had told me, the laws of physics did indeed apply here, but energy and thought projection were merely twisted in a unique way, allowing one to bend the rules using sheer willpower.

"We need reinforcements!" The enemy cowered behind their massive castle walls.

"Your walls will not avail you!" I aimed a hand at one of their trebuchets. " **MISSILE!** " An actual missile, created from my imagination, that resembled a Stinger missile from my own world, flew at the trebuchet. The person manning it leaped off the side, just in time as it erupted in a fiery blast.

The enemy was panicking. Amelia licked her lips, as her sword of darkness sliced through yet another foe. "Hero! The time is upon us! Use it!"

I lifted my sword, the mighty Excalibur! Aiming it towards the heavens I shouted again.

"**METEOR!!!!**"

From the cloudy sky that poured down rain, a massive rock suddenly appeared. Aimed at the castle under siege, it began a rapid descent. The clouds parted and the rain ceased as a beam of sunlight broke through, blinding the defenders.

"You think a puny rock will be the death of me?!" The mighty Devil Emperor, Satan, stood at the top of the castle. "Behold my unholy power!"

Making some admittedly fancy hand motions, he suddenly summoned a massive Earth Golem, towering above the battlefield, built from the stone bricks that made up the castle itself. His troops cheered as the Golem reared back, and punched upwards, just in time to smash into the descending meteor. I smiled. All according to plan.

The power of the impact shattered both of them into a million pieces, the debris rained down on the battlefield, rocks smashing into my troops and Satan's troops alike. Satan looked down and suddenly realized the mistake he'd made. The golem had been formed out of the mighty walls of the Necropolis. Now there gaped a titanic hole for my troops to pour through.

Aiming my hands at my feet, I yelled again. " **Agility!** " Before Satan could get his bearings, I leaped into the sky, aiming my trajectory right at the Devil himself. "This will be your end, Devil!"

Sheating my sword in midair, I pulled my hands behind my body, and began to chant.

" *Kaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaa-meeeeeeeeeeeeeeeeeeeeee...* "

Satan shook with fear. "Who is this Hero that he could break through my defenses so easily?!" Many of his demonic generals nearby begin to edge away from him in fear as they realized I was aiming at him.

" **HAAAAAAAAA-MEEEEEEEEEEEEEE-** "

Satan screamed in terror. "Protect me!!!"

Instead, his troops fled. None could defend against this attack. Many threw themselves from the walls to the grounds below, killing themselves in fright.

"-**HAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAA!!!!**"

* * *

I rose out of bed with a start. Damnit. That was a good dream.

Part 043:

I rolled out of bed and gave a slow yawn, glancing out the window at the darkness. "That didn't feel like a dream."

It felt so real. I could have sworn that I was really there, fighting Satan the Devil in the darkest towers of Hell.

It felt so real...

I contemplated the dream. Was it really a dream? I'd never experienced something so vivid. And more interestingly, everything that happened in the dream seemed *plausible*. Like, it could really happen.

Other parts still bugged me though. Amelia had wielded a massive dark sword. I already knew her aura was pitch black, but the sword itself was so black that it had to have been made or summoned by her aura. It's the only thing that made sense.

And what about my attacks? I felt like all of them were plausible. Except... maybe the missile.

Amelia was sleeping in another room of Bahamut's former castle, so I decided to take some quiet time to myself. I want to test some things.

Walking down the hall, Hoarhiim appeared in my mind. "What are you up to this late at night, Hero?"

He called me Hero. Not the Child of Gaia. Had I gained a new title, or a new name? Was it related to the events of yesterday? The people of the city had cheered loudly that I was a Hero, and since then everyone simply calls me Hero. It would seem that my original name has disappeared. Nobody has called me the Child of Gaia even once since that incident.

"I'm thinking about a great many things, Hoarhiim." I responded to him a few seconds after he had asked me. "Hoarhiim, do you remember what you called me when we first met?"

Hoarhiim looked confused. "Of course I do. I have a perfect memory, I called you the Hero, the Chosen One."

Now I am confused. Was my 'name' somehow overwritten in the minds of this world's denizens? Not only that, but what a crazy name! Hero. That sounded ominous. I'm not even that powerful compared to others in this world. Shoot, even Amelia is more powerful than I am.

Or is she? It's as Hoarhiim told me once, it doesn't matter if you have a lot of power if you can't use it well. Naturally Amelia can use her power well, she's definitely not a young child. I

don't know how old she is, and it would be rude to ask, but based on the ages of other citizens I've met, she's probably hundreds of years old. Something about this place seems to make people that live here age slowly. I'm literally an infant compared to everyone else I've met.

That alone means I need to not only be more careful, but get some training in. Now that I have a safe place to train, I should stay here for a while and get some work done.

"Hoarhiim, what do you know about my powers?"

He seemed thoughtful for a minute, thinking as I walked towards a small, quiet room deep in the palace. Hoarhiim lit the way as I walked, so the darkness didn't cause me any trouble.

"Well... you're certainly unusual. Nobody has responded to my spiritual energy quite like you have." Hoarhiim halted, as if he was unsure of what to say. Nevertheless, I had an idea of what to try next.

Finding myself a spot on the hard tiled floor in a small, quiet room. I set Hoarhiim on the ground in front of me for light. "I'm going to try something new."

I'd never done this before, but if my dream was any indication, I may have the possibility inside me.

Holding my palm upwards, aimed nowhere in particular, but facing the ceiling, I chanted.

" *Spoon.* "

I was only partially surprised to see a spoon appear in my hands. It looked just like the spoons in the silverware set my aunt had given me for christmas a few years before I entered the Cryopod. I tried bending it, and found that it was surprisingly sturdy.

"How did you do that?" Hoarhiim eyed the spoon in my hand. "That looks like a solid object. Is its energy going to dissipate?"

I shook my head. "I don't think so. I think I've just discovered something incredibly useful."

I once again held my hand up.

" *Spoon.* "

This time, I visualized a wooden cooking spoon. In my minds eye, I pictured myself making spaghetti and meatballs with it. It was the kind of wooden spoon you'd use for cooking.

And I was not surprised to see it appear in my hand. It would seem that it's not just the word, but intent, and a mental image of mine that shapes the effect of the spell.

Of course, Hoarhiim was linked to my mind, so he was processing things as I did them and reading my thoughts as well.

"Incredible. You're forming solid objects out of spiritual energy. Such a thing shouldn't be possible. For example, if you wanted to form a sword, you could, but it would be dependant on your spiritual energy reserves and would drain you as you used it. Also, it would be made of energy, nothing corporeal."

I nodded. Actually, he had given me an idea.

Without raising my hand this time, I stared at an empty spot on the ground.

" *Longsword* "

Imagining the sword in my dreams from last night, I pictured a sword made out of titanium, with a fancy golden hilt, and a ruby inset in that hilt.

And poof, there it appeared. Up until now, I had always used my hand to cast spells, but it seems that I didn't have to do that at all.

I picked the sword up as I stood. Brushing myself off, I spotted a pillar in the room. I swung the sword at it, and the sword bounced off with a *TWANG!* The sword also wobbled a little bit at the center of the blade.

Hmm. I set the sword back on the ground, and stared at it.

" **Strengthen!** "

The sword did not seem to noticeably change. I picked it up, and swung at the pillar of stone once more. This time, the sword cut slightly into it and got stuck. I pulled hard and managed to pull it out.

Hoarhiim quietly eyed what I was doing with interest. In thousands of years, he'd never seen anything like this. But that's because he wasn't from my time or world or wherever I came from. He wasn't familiar with the concept of scientific engineering, nor building things from your imagination.

I turned again to the sword. " **Sharpen!** "

I picked it up, and swung at the pillar. This time, I sliced right through the pillar as if it didn't exist. The pillar shifted slightly and luckily didn't make the roof cave in and collapse on top of me. Whew, I still need to be more careful.

Perfect. I have an idea.

Part 044: Dellfingler

Heh heh heh... they can't laugh at me anymore. I'm a goddamn genius.

I stifled a bout of maniacal laughter in my mind. It was so brilliant it wounded me. I could create anything using my magical powers. I wasn't just different, I was a walking cheat code.

I aimed my hand at the sword. It wasn't necessary anymore, but I still preferred to do it. It helped with the mental imagery.

" *Sentience* "

To be honest, I didn't know what to expect, but I had to try it.

* * *

Nothing happened. I stared at the sword on the ground. Damn. I guess even I have limits. I'm not a God, it would appear.

I reached for the sword. The moment I touched it... the sword *screamed*.

"HEY! GET YOUR GRUBBY MITTS OFF ME!"

I nearly jumped out of my skin, and found my body scrambling away in fright towards the other side of the room. Holy shit! It worked! I hadn't imagined anything specific when I cast the spell, only that I wanted to somehow make the sword 'alive'.

"Oh great. Thanks a lot. You created me with life, you left me lying here NAKED on the cold floor, and now you're scared of me. What a piece of shit." The sword was cursing at me. What the hell.

"Uh... I didn't actually, expect that to work." I walked back over and sat down with the Sword in front of me. "Do you, I guess, have a name?"

The sword coughed. Where was its voice coming from? "Heck yeah buddy, my name's Dellfingler! Don't you forget it!" I guess he was already over his anger from earlier.

Huh, it had a name.

"Okay, so I gave you life, what now? Got any special abilities?"

The sword didn't even hesitate. "No."

I frowned. "Nothing badass, like Soul Ignition, or Mind Meld, or shooting out a spiritual energy blade when I swing?"

"No."

"Well okay, then what DO you do that a normal sword doesn't?"

The sword's response felt like it was shrugging its shoulders. It didn't even have shoulders. "Nothing. I can talk though!"

Fantastic, the power to annoy my enemies while I cut them down.

As I considered these things, Amelia walked in the room. Huh, she wasn't asleep? How did she find me? Blaarjiim must truly be the Lord of Darkness.

Amelia must have caught the tail end of our conversation. "Oh wow! You found a sword that can talk! That's *so* cool!" I mean, I didn't *find* the sword per se, but she's dense so I'll let it slide.

She immediately grabbed Dellfingler up and he didn't offer a trace of verbal resistance. I see how it is.

When she lifted him up, I noticed something disturbing. The Ruby that was inset into the hilt, it had something resembling a pupil moving around inside it. I was instantly reminded of Sauron.

"Oh wow! I can see! Thank you so much, my beautiful queen!"

The voice appeared to be coming out of the ruby. Audible thought projection? She hopped up and down with glee.

"Did you hear that? Did you hear that, Hero? He called me a queen! What excellent manners he has to recognize my beauty and superior royal aura!" She fluffed her hair back haughtily and struck a pose with the sword. "This does it! I'm keeping this sword for my own!"

I shrugged. I could always make another one. And to be honest, a talking sword would get pretty annoying.

Thinking about my options, I wondered to myself if another option might be possible.

I looked at the ground again. I imagined something incredible. There's no way this thing could exist normally, but maybe here it could...

Gathering my power, I spoke one word.

"*Lightsaber.*"

Part 045: Jedi

I stared at the ground. Nothing was there.

Focusing my mind again, I pictured it once again. The switch to flip, the spot for energy to blast out the tip, the handheld size of just under 9 inches long.

" *Lightsaber.* "

...Nothing appeared. Damnit! Was it because Lightsaber is actually two words? It's written as one though! Maybe my powers don't count words like that? That's stupid! Or maybe it's because there's no actual way to examine how it works. Lightsabers are fictional weapons, and they have never been successfully created.

Amelia stared at me. "What... what are you doing?"

I frowned hard and kept staring at the ground. "I'm trying to create a really awesome weapon, but it's not working."

"Ah." She seemed bored. She was swinging Dellfingler around, having a jolly good time talking with it. Apparently Dellfingler was really into fashion, something I'd never expect for a sentient sword.

I stared at the ground more intently. Alright, if a Lightsaber isn't appearing, let's try something else.

" *Rifle.* "

And lo and behold! A lever action rifle appeared in front of me! I had no clue what model it was as I'm not actually a gun enthusiast, but this was a start. I picked it up and jumped to my feet. Aiming it towards the empty side of the room, I fired at the wall.

Nothing happened.

Well, duh, stupid. It doesn't have ammo. Except, I couldn't visualize how to spawn ammo. I only vaguely know how guns work. I never really studied them before I came here. I know there's a trigger, some kind of lever pops in, hits the backside of the bullet which is filled with gunpowder, and a spark or something ignites the bullet, propelling it forwards into the body of my foes.

And then I realized. I could create anything I desired, but only if I had exact knowledge of what I wanted to do. It wasn't actually as much of a cheat code as I'd thought. I can't just invent things unless I have an understanding of the physics that go into its use. Simple implements like

swords and spoons are okay, but complex mechanical parts would be tricky or outright impossible.

Damn, there goes my lifelong dream of being a Jedi. I jokingly mused that I even had Force Push and Pull at my disposal.

Wait, I suddenly had one hell of a thought spring to mind.

I turned to Amelia. "Hey, can you do me a favor?"

Amelia stopped chatting with Dellfingler. "Huh? What do you want? I'm busy."

Sitting back down on the floor, I stared at the ground again.

" *Bow.* "

A small shortbow appeared. Bows were easy. They were bent wood with a string. It didn't look like the cool ones I'd seen in professional Archery matches on TV, but it was serviceable for what I needed.

" *Arrow* "

An arrow appeared. I cast this spell a few more times and then summoned a quiver.

"Amelia, have you ever shot a bow and arrow before?" Standing up, I held the bow and a single arrow in my hand and drew them in a half cocked position, aiming them away from both of us and down at the floor. Safety first!

Amelia shook her head. "No. What is that strange implement anyway?" Walking over a bit closer to me, she eyed it up and down. "What does that even do? It looks weird."

Strange. I had thought maybe she'd never fired a bow and arrow before, but she appeared to have not even *heard* of them before. Maybe it's been millions of years since people needed anything but magic for attacks.

I demonstrated for her how to fire it. Taking aim at a makeshift target I had spawned, I fired and it stuck somewhere near the top of it.

She nodded. "Alright. Seems easy enough. What do you want me to do though?"

I handed the bow to her. "Easy. I want you to shoot at me, and I'm going to stop it in midair." *Like a Jedi*, I thought to myself. Oh man, this is going to be cool as shit.

Running over on the opposite side of the room, I got into position directly across from her. Gathering my energy around me, I cast a spell I remembered from my dream.

" **Barrier!** "

A barrier appeared around my body. It appeared to hover a few inches from my skin in every possible direction around me. Just in case something went wrong, this would protect me from a

dangerous mishap. Safety first! I'm not making the same mistake as I made last time, this time there would be precautions taken.

" *Perception.*"

In my mind, I imagined myself perceiving time slowing down, the ability to think more quickly, so that I could see things coming before they happened. This was easy. When she fired the arrow, I was going to cast 'Deflect' and knock it out of the air, just like a Jedi would. Oh man, this is too easy.

"Alright Amelia, fire at me, but for this first shot, try not to hit me, just aim for the side of me. I don't want to accidentally fail and get shot."

Not that it really matters. This is her first time ever shooting a bow. She's probably going to miss completely and try a few more times before she can even hit me.

"Okay!" She shouted cheerfully. She looked so cute with that bow and arrow in her hand and the sword at her waist, like a little female Robin Hood.

She pulled the bow up and took aim. Her stance though... she looked like a seasoned professional. "Are you sure you've never fired an arrow before?"

"Nope!" *I have a baaaad feeling about this*, I found myself thinking.

I willed time to slow down. My speed perception of things increased a hundredfold, I noticed a fly buzzing around the room slowly, as if it were swimming through honey in the air. Amelia's breathing was imperceptible.

I raised my hand up, realizing my actual speed was not increased, so my hand seemed to take a whole minute to raise. Shit, I should have boosted my speed first. "Wait Ame-"

And then she fired.

BOOM!

An arrow was instantly buried right in my gut, then it passed through me, and smashed through three layers of walls behind me. WHAM, WHAM, WHAM!

I whipped my head back around to see a colossal pile of devastation behind me. And then I suddenly realized there was a massive fucking hole in my abdomen.

I turned back right as the pain hit me, staggering forwards. Amelia looked totally unconcerned. She shrugged as our eyes met.

"Oops."

Part 046: Regret

It's been a month now.

A month ago, I made a mistake. It nearly cost me my life. I underestimated Fate.

I thought of myself as invincible. " *I am a walking cheat code* ", that was how I thought. But I was wrong. I'm not a cheat code. I'm not invincible. I'm not a genius.

I was lying in Bahamut's bed, her sacred throne room she had spent millennia or eons perfecting. It was exquisite, rich golden tapestries hung from the ceiling, the bed itself had beautiful golden pillars, there were paintings from artists I'd never heard of that dazzled the imagination. Depictions of heaven, hell, possibly even Earth. The floor was a perfectly carved marble, all the pieces meshed together as if they had never been cut at all.

And I hated the sight of all of it.

For an entire month, I've laid in this bed.

I cannot move from it. I cannot leave from it.

When Amelia struck me with the arrow, she was wholly unconcerned. *Oops*. It was a harmless gag. She had healing magic. It hurt like hell, but even I wasn't completely worried. This was a world of magic. I've had all the bones in my body broken and shattered before and I've been healed from that in hours. In fact, I've had it happen twice.

But not this time. Her shot was powerful, insanely powerful. It shredded my spine into a million pieces. My spine effectively evaporated. I couldn't even move my arms without monumental effort, but my legs were completely lifeless.

For an entire month, I've laid here in this bed. What was I thinking? A hero? I'm nothing. I don't have the power to save anyone, I can't even save myself.

Minutes turned into hours and hours turned into days, which became weeks, which became a month. The world soldiers on, but I lie here crippled, a broken husk.

Amelia has come in quietly to check on me and talk with me, but she's not full of energy. She's completely forlorn. I can't believe I'm saying this, but I think she feels *guilty*. And she probably should. But the look of guilt when she sees me in the bed... I just want to end it all. I can't stand seeing her like that. I can't stand seeing myself like this.

Is there no hope? Is there any way to save myself? Nothing comes to mind. Perhaps I will have to live the rest of my life as an invalid.

The worst part is, I'm so fucking tired of eating this chicken.

Part 047: Resolve

I'm tired of this. I'm so tired of this hell.

Three months now. I'm getting weaker and weaker. Amelia barely even visits anymore. Servants bring me food (always chicken) and water and attend to my needs. I may be crippled badly but I'm still a hero to these people.

What the hell is wrong with me? These people depended on me. I gave them salvation and immediately became a cripple. Talk about being a flash in the pan hero.

Frustration was building. Damnit! I can't stand being like this. I'd rather be dead! But then again, the thought that dying might send me to that lake of fire and acid didn't exactly fuel my excitement.

I pondered and thought, and pondered some more.

Come on, there HAS to be a way to fix this. I'm in a world that defies human imagination. I'm in a world where I can summon swords and create sentient beings with a single word. There's no way this condition isn't a temporary one.

Yeah! That's it! There has to be a way out of this! I've been in worse predicaments! Even if it takes time, I've got all the time in the world! I practically live in a giant safe room!

Thoughts crossed my mind. Physical therapy? Maybe doing small exercises daily would help me recuperate. I remember a famous actor, Christopher Reeves, he was completely paralyzed after an accident involving a horse that threw him off, and while he did eventually die years later, he had been able to move his body to a decent extent after years of therapy.

But... even though I may have all the time in the world, that didn't mean I had to do it that way. There were literally thousands of people with magic that could help me.

Shit, this is hurting my head to think about. Maybe there's some way I can think more clearly.

* * *

Oh right, the Crown of Solomon. Duh. I really am still an idiot.

I had left the Crown on a desk nearby, but in my condition two feet might as well have been two solar systems away. I rang my bell nearby and called out for one of my servants. "Phoebe! Phoebe! Are you there?"

She came around the corner. She was an older looking woman, maybe in her 40's, at least looks-wise. Actual age-wise, who knew? She could be 20 million years old for all I know. Her

hair was a bouncy blonde, with natural curls going all the way down. She had a small scar on her right cheek that she insisted was from a dog, but I wasn't so sure.

She walked into my room, smoothing down her maid outfit to preserve her modesty. "Ah, Great Hero, how may I be of service to you today?"

"Would you mind grabbing the Crown off the desk for me? I need to do some thinking." I beckoned with my eyes at it.

"Are you sure, Great Hero? You said it was hurting your head when you wore it in bed." She seemed concerned for my well being. It was very touching.

"Yes, it will be quite all right, it's only for a short while."

She nodded quickly. "Of course! Anything for you, oh Great One!" She walked over to the desk quickly and plucked it off, admiring it for a second before handing it to me. "Such a beautiful thing. I can see why you like it. Would you like me to put it on your head?"

I nodded. "Yes, that would be great. Thank you, Phoebe."

"Not at all! Anything for you!" She quickly pulled it back out of my hands and set it on my head gently. "Will there be anything else?"

I didn't hear what she had just said. Suddenly, my mind was racing. The instant she placed the Crown on my head, my brain started thinking at the speed of light. I had forgotten what a rush wearing the crown was. Wearing it for such a prolonged period of time must have dulled how overwhelming it was to me. It's like having a cut on your arm. When it's fresh, you feel the pain. After a while, the pain diminishes, and soon you won't notice it at all unless you think about it consciously or poke the wound.

Thinking about my condition, a million possibilities came to my mind. Magic, treatment, cure, fix, heal, words came at me faster and faster.

Suddenly I jerked my head up and stared straight at Phoebe.

"Say, Phoebe, do you recall where I put those two extra rings of mine?"

Part 048: Choice

I stared at the two rings cupped gently in my hand.

Phoebe had left me alone with them, as I requested. She was really a sweet lady, a great servant, and a good friend. She had been there for me more than anyone else. When the phantom pains hit and I was crying and writhing in agony, she always held my hand.

If I ever got out of this bed, I'd make sure she was well off before I continued my adventure. She deserved that much.

The rings in my hand silently clinked together and rolled apart, then they clinked together again as I rolled them around slowly.

Which ring should I use first? Would they even do anything?

I stared long and hard at them.

Raphael, the Wisdom King. Michael, the Divine King. These had to be beings of awe inspiring power. If they could not heal me, who could?

But would they? Did I deserve to be healed?

Doubt took hold. Why would they heal me, a lowly human, posing as some fanciful hero? I only have the powers that I do because of luck. I was lucky to find Hoarhiim. I was lucky to find the Crown. I was lucky that Amelia wasn't a cursed demon that wanted to eat me. I was lucky that she could heal my broken body. I was lucky that the riddle was the sphinx's riddle. I was lucky to have survived this long in the first place.

I have no real skills. All I have is luck. If I were an RPG character, all my other stats would be 0, my Luck would be infinite. What have I done to deserve being healed? Nothing. That was the answer. Absolutely nothing.

But... if I were to be healed. I should no longer be an arrogant fool. I should think my actions through more carefully. I should focus on helping others for the sake of helping them, not to focus on my own gain.

I nudged my finger towards one of the two rings. *Raphael.* Give me the wisdom to make the right decisions.

Part 049: Raphael

I braced myself for the feeling of falling, and then I slipped the ring on my finger.

As usual, I was surprised yet again.

The world around me darkened noticeably. The daylight (Of which I still couldn't figure out where exactly it came from) vanished, and darkness took over my vision. Suddenly I was in a world of black.

And then, things cleared up. Above me, I saw a starry sky. Trees were all over around me. I found myself seated on a log, sitting a few feet from a cozy fire. I lifted my hands up and felt the warmth from the fire.

Was this an illusion? I blinked twice. It seemed so real. I could feel my body again. I was sitting upright without any support. It felt somehow exhilarating. Had I already been healed? This was probably just an illusion.

Suddenly, I realized I was not alone. Across from me, an old man sat quietly, on the opposite side of the fire.

For a minute, the silence increased. I felt the urge to speak, since he didn't appear to want to.

"Are... you Raphael?" I asked slowly, almost not sure if I should break the silence.

The old man stared stonily at the fire, his hands held up to keep warm. The chilly night air was bitter cold, but it felt good to me who had been cooped up indoors for so long.

He was an interesting looking fellow. He would seem to be a hundred years old, by his appearance. His long beard flowed beneath him, mottled by years he had spent not combing it. It lightly touched the ground thanks to his hunched position. His hair was grey and thinning. He wore a robe that covered most of his body, though his face was fully visible.

Unsure if he had not heard me, I tried again. "Ah, sir... could you perhaps be the Archangel Raphael?"

Sir. I may have just called a heavenly divine being 'Sir'. What the hell is wrong with me? I'm so inept at conversing with other people. This is what I get for spending my last three years in the past as a shut-in, watching TV and playing video games.

The old man slowly raised his gaze to meet mine. "...And what if I am? What would you do? What would you ask of me?"

I was taken aback by his questions. What would I do? I don't know. I just wanted... to talk. He was the great Archangel of Wisdom. Perhaps he could help me.

Then I suddenly felt embarrassed. Really, me? I'm going to just bug a great heavenly being with inane questions about myself? I just want to bother him so he can heal my broken back? I'm still only thinking of myself. Why did I even do this? I only came here for myself. I'm full of selfishness and greediness. I shouldn't have come here.

I reached for my finger, intending to take off Raphael's ring, but it wasn't there.

The old man, perhaps reading my thoughts, spoke again. "So full of doubt and self loathing. I have met many like you." He lowered his eyes, and again stared into the fire. I could almost believe I saw visions in his ancient eyes. Visions of wars fought, friends lost, companions slain. The man had lost family and friends, wives and children, he had lost everything and in the end, he had failed them all.

I was silent. I didn't have anything to say.

"Everyone has doubt. They always ask what could have been. They always ask 'what if'. They always want to know what the right choices are to make." The old man, spoke, as he stared into the fire. "Many have sought my counsel. They call me 'wise'. I am not wise, I am simply ancient. I have seen a great many things and lived a great many lives."

He rose up slowly, his hand resting on a mottled old cane as he lifted himself to his full height. He was not particularly tall, in fact, he seemed to be nearly the same height as myself.

"Wisdom is not gained through counsel or words. Wisdom is not gained through questions and answers. Wisdom, if such a thing truly exists, can only be cultivated through deeds, both honorable and dishonorable."

He hobbled slowly around the fire towards me. When he reached me, I gazed up into his eyes.

He leaned down to me and pressed a hand upon my shoulder.

"You do not need my counsel. I can only give you words and concepts. The solution to your problem lies within yourself. All you have to do, is *look* for it."

Suddenly, I felt a great energy emanating from his hand that was placed on my shoulder.

"Go now, Hero. Do what must be done. When I next see you, it will be I who asks the questions, not ye."

And with that, the world around me dissipated. The old man faded away, as did the night sky and the stars, and I found myself once again laying in my bed.

I stared at the ceiling in wonder. It all meant something grand, and incredible.

But now I knew what had to be done.

Taking the final ring, I placed my finger inside it.

Michael.

Part 050: Michael

A lush field of green as far as the eye could see. I sat at the bottom of a gently sloping hill, covered in grass and flowers. All around me was flatland, with trees and mountains in the distance. The sun gently beat upon my chest, as the scent of daffodils wafted in the wind.

I looked around me. I saw rabbits, and deer, and other such creatures frolicking in the meadows. A distance away, there was a stream with fish bobbing for flies and bugs. The scene was serene and somber.

As I stared to my side at the stream, something blotted out the rising sun out of the corner of my vision, I looked up and gasped as I saw a great maned lion appear on the top of the hill. A fearsome creature, he dwarfed me with his size, standing nearly ten feet tall and fifteen feet long. His massive hulking muscles showed he possessed the body of a true predator. Atop his head he wore a golden crown, far more glamorous than my own Crown of Solomon.

"Could you be... Michael?" I spoke aloud, directing my question at the lion. In the Bible, I remembered that Michael the Archangel was often described as a mighty Lion. This had to be him.

The lion seemed to not even notice my presence. His mighty gaze stared off into the distance, far behind me, as if searching for a new prey. I did not even register his interest.

Suddenly, I felt a presence beside me. Looking up and to my left, I saw a man, clothed all in white robes. A shortly cropped, neatly clipped beard covered his face, and the color was the same as his neck-length hair, pure black. Wearing a crown of thorns, and carrying a massive cross on his back as blood dripped from his head, the man seemed to be in great need of help.

"Why have you come to me?" the man asked, his voice decidedly neutral considering the strain placed on his body by the heavy wooden structure. "Have you come to pity me, as my friends and enemies alike have done?"

I stared at the wooden cross, it was a sturdy thing, made of solid oak with splinters sticking out here and there, surely digging into his back and arms.

I lowered my gaze to the ground in front of me. "How could I pity you? You were willing to make the ultimate sacrifice to save humanity. You were willing to do whatever it took to spread your word to the furthest reaches of the world. I cannot pity one who was a true Hero when the time was needed."

The man spoke softly. "But I knew that in death, I would receive the greatest reward, a throne at the side of my Father. Knowing that my death would cost me nothing, could I still be called a Hero?"

He pulled back and threw his cross to the side. It smashed into the grass with a soft "*Whump*". I raised my eyes to follow his path. Walking towards the top of the hill, he pulled off his white garment to reveal a muscular body, beaten and bruised with whips and clubs.

"Yes, you were a true Hero. Despite knowing you would be rewarded greatly for your deeds, you still suffered greatly as well. I do not know that if I were in your position that I could have gone through with it, even with such a divine reward at the end of the journey." I smiled as he walked up the hill and climbed astride the great Lion.

"You are not so different from me. I was merely a carpenter's son who wished to heal the world. To stop the lies and create the truth, I would have done anything." He raised his eyes to the sky, admiring a cloud that passed overhead.

The lion slowly stirred, and walked down the hill towards me, the man safely straddling it without using his grip. "The most important thing that I discovered during my journey was this: My reward was not my uplifting to the heavens. My greatest reward was that I was able to give a pathway for humanity to heal."

Reaching the bottom of the grassy knoll, he pointed his finger at me.

"Go and be healed, my child. When the time comes, I trust that you will make the right choice, and someday you will be able to respect yourself. Not as a Hero, but as a Hero King."

A bright light came out of his fingertip. It was blinding, brighter than a million suns. I screamed wordlessly as a terrible pain overtook my entire body. My vision became white hot as the world around me burned away. The agony I felt was worse than anything the Hell I had lived in for the last several months could possibly do to me.

And then I awoke. I was in my bed, I could feel my arms and legs once again. I felt a small joy creep into my chest as my heart leaped for joy.

But something was wrong. All around me, everything was black. I felt my face. Something felt wrong. I blinked hard, over and over, but the pitch blackness would not go away.

I was... *blind*?

Part 051:

I couldn't believe my eyes! It was a miracle!

I walked back into the room to check on the Hero's needs and was flabbergasted to see him standing in the corner of the room, staring out the window. Standing! He was healed! The greatest mages in the city, his own power, and the great Lord of Flies herself had lacked the ability to heal him, yet there he stood.

Rushing over to him, I stood a few feet away and called out his name.

"Hero! Great Hero! It's a miracle, you're walking!" I looked him up and down. He was not very tall, and his body had atrophied from being denied movement thanks to his condition for the last few months, yet here he stood, more filled with life than I had seen since I first met him.

From behind him, I saw a small gentle smile tighten across his the side of his face as he gazed out the window. "Ah, Phoebe. Is that you?"

I felt a small bit of confusion. "Yes, Great Hero. It is I. Do you not remember me?"

He slowly turned around and his eyes mindlessly wandered all over the room, failing to set themselves on my figure. They were a cloudy white color, searching everything but finding nothing. "Ah... well, it's just so... hard to comprehend my thoughts right now. Indescribable, really."

"Your... your eyes... what happened...?" I swallowed as I looked into the Hero's empty eyes.

"Phoebe. I can't see you right now. As a condition for my healing, or perhaps it was because I needed to make a willful sacrifice, the one who healed me made me blind. Perhaps, by making me blind, he wanted me to see things as they really are." Hero nodded slowly. "Yes, that must be it. This was no accident, nor is it a curse. Rather, this is something I must accept and learn to live with."

I was flabbergasted. "W-what?! Someone had the power to heal you but after doing so they... they struck you with a curse?! How could you accept this?! If you hold for but a short while, I shall fetch the Lord of Flies, curing blindness is a snap compared to healing your spine!" I started to turn for the door.

"Wait. Don't go." Hero held up his hand, indicating the 'halt' sign. "Do not do that. This is not a curse. In fact, I consider this a blessing."

Hero put his hand down and slowly walked over to his bed, fumbling for handholds along the way, missing the bottom corner of the bed with his foot by mere centimeters. Finding a

handhold, he slowly sat down on the bed and stared at the ground. I walked over and took a seat next to him.

"If you won't heal your eyesight, then what will you do?"

A simple question. How could the Hero be a savior of the people if he was still a cripple who could not walk anywhere without a cane to search out the path in front of him?

"This blindness allows me to see many things I could not see before. It also allows me to close out things I did not want to see. I no longer see the River of Sheol, as an example."

I felt a shudder go down my spine. The River of Sheol. He had told me about it. A hellish river where the souls of the damned go to forever live and writhe in the worst agony possible. A place I should never like to go.

Hero cracked a huge grin suddenly and rose quickly to his feet. "However, I do not need to see with my eyes to see the destiny laid out in front of me. I know what must be done."

Raising his hand forwards, he spoke a single word.

" **Detect.** "

Part 052:

At first, nothing happened.

Then, the world of black started to turn into a foggy white. All around me, near and far, I was able to make out the outlines of various objects, walls, and things moving around. They were hazy and indistinct, yet somehow more vivid than I remembered from my normal vision.

A rat scurried by me and almost by instinct, I jerked away from it, only to realize that it was inside the confines of the wall, scurrying around. This meant that I could see through walls, in a way.

I pondered this. The last time I had used Detect, I was only able to see red dots that indicated life forms. Now, I could see far more detail, not just for the life forms, but also the things surrounding me. If I concentrated, I could even 'will' my mind to spatially travel to another area for recon or surveillance.

What had caused the difference though? It was hard to pin down. I had put more energy into it this time, for sure. But I also had needed to detect a lot more than I did the first time I cast it, so perhaps my mental image of what I needed to detect was different. And finally, with my vision gone, perhaps my need for higher levels of detection was important.

Phoebe stared at me. "What did you just do, Hero?"

I walked around the room, kicking things out of the way as I tested depth perception and other things. My head was unmoving, as I did not see anything with my eyes, but with my entire mind. In a way, it's like whatever room I was in, my mind filled up the room and allowed me to see everything around me in a complete sphere.

"I guess you could say that I can see again."

Phoebe seemed delighted. "That's wonderful! You truly are a genius magician! I shall fetch us some celebratory tea at once!" She jumped up and left the room with a hop and a skip in her step.

I smiled wryly. I'm no genius, I simply now understand what I have to do, and I won't let anything get in my way.

Walking over to a dresser nearby, I sensed the immense spiritual presence of Hoarhiim. With my new vision, I saw him as a miniature sun, blinding with his immense spiritual energy. He seemed *brighter* than before, if that was even possible. He was sitting in a basket with cloth

and other such things in it. Phoebe had put him in the basket to keep him 'comfortable' even though he felt no physical sensations.

It's been three months since the accident, and at the moment I was impacted by that arrow, he had ceased to speak. I had heard nothing from him whatsoever. Blaarjiim had mentioned that it may be 'spiritual trauma' due to our shared mind-link and the overwhelming pain I had felt, but I was not sure.

I wrapped Hoarhiim up in a specially made belt that one of the many attendants in the palace had crafted for me. I nestled snugly on my waist without shaking around.

Phoebe came back in the room with some tea and we sat down at a small nearby table with two seats.

After sipping and thinking quietly for a while, Phoebe also drinking quietly, probably not wanting to interrupt my thoughts, I broke the silence.

"Phoebe, have you seen Amelia recently?"

Phoebe perked up and then instantly calmed back down again. "Oh, ah, I didn't have the chance to tell you yet. She and Kar, they both went out together."

I frowned as I sipped. "Out? Like uh, on a... date?"

Phoebe seemed confused. "I don't know what a date is, but they left the City of Bahamut and re-entered the labyrinth two days ago. I didn't want to tell you because you might be..." She tilted her head away and let her words drift off. Ah, she didn't tell me because she didn't want to depress me any further. It made sense. Until recently I was withering away in that bed. It was almost a crime that Phoebe treated me as well as she did. I couldn't have been much of a conversationalist.

Other thoughts entered my mind. Hoarhiim had been silent for three months, even now he seemed to be not responding to me. Amelia and Kar were gone, along with Blaarjiim. The party that had grown so big was split up and at least temporarily disbanded.

Yet, I felt a new emotion coursing through my veins. I couldn't quite describe it, but I guess 'Drive' would be the word. I felt a drive to start improving my body, to start improving my mind, to perfect my spiritual power until I was a worthy hero.

After finishing my tea, I stood up. "Thank you, that was excellent as usual."

"It was my pleasure!" Phoebe beamed a big wide smile at me.

Taking the cups and some other nearby dishes from an earlier meal, Phoebe exited the room quietly to go and clean them up. I paced back and forth slowly, finding myself drawn to the nearby window.

I could feel heat on my body, but I couldn't see the sun outside. I was blind, and yet could see with new clarity. I could count the blades of grass in the field outside mentally in an instant. Had something else changed recently? Was I simply finally able to use the full power of the Crown of Solomon, or might this be due to a hidden power that Raphael had given me?

Opening up the window, I hopped over one in a single swoop and landed on the ground stiffly. Walking over to the grass I sat in a meditative position.

It's time to *train*.

Part 053: Journey

Today is a great day!!!

I mean, it's ALWAYS a great day, but today I just feel especially great! I don't have to hang around that sulking sad kid who thinks he's the shit. No way, no sir!

I patted my dress down and hopped and skipped as I walked. Kar and I had hung out for a while, but he's a total snooze so he went back home to his people. Now it's just me, Blaarjiim, and all the innocent souls I'm going to devour! Teehee!

I entered a room filled with all sorts of pretty lights, with a delightful stream of blood that was splashing out of one wall, crossing the path in front of me, and draining itself through a crack in the bottom of the adjacent wall. Dipping my fingers in it, I licked them. Mmm! Yummy!

"I see you're having a good time, as you always are, my queen." Blaarjiim piped up, probably getting jealous that I was licking the tasty blood and he couldn't enjoy it.

"Hey! You could have had some if you hadn't sealed yourself in that stupid orb!" I chided him, holding him in my left hand and wagging my right hand's finger at him.

"I had to do that. You already know why." His voice sounded kinda sad. Oh well, he can't actually be sad or anything, he lacks all emotion!

After a while, I hopped and skipped along until I came to the big door I had been looking for. "Oh wow, we're already here! This is great!"

"Of course, my queen. Your speed is only eclipsed by your beauty and grace." Aww, he's so sweet! For a Lord of Darkness, he sure is such a softie!

With a light tap, I gently nudged the door open, sending it careening through the air, smashing into the open field. "Hey guys, it's me! The Lord of Flies!"

Suddenly, screams were everywhere. All the humans tending to their farms and crops suddenly tossed their tools on the ground and started fleeing in terror.

"She's here! The dark witch is here!!! Call the Hunters, call the guards! DAMNIT call anybody!!!" A poor unfortunate man was screaming such nasty things about me. For his information, I'm a dark QUEEN, thank you very much!

In a flash I zipped over to him and popped off his head, my mouth enlarging big enough to quickly chew his bones into dust. I'm pretty sure he died before he even knew what hit him XD

A lady and her child were cowering in terror, their tender looking bodies quivering in fear. "Foul demon! Why must you appear and plague us? What have we done to offend you?!"

I actually had to think about it for a second. "Blaarjiim, did they do anything to upset me?"

He seemed disinterested. "No, my queen. They simply fill you up with souls."

I nodded giddily. "That's right! They make the yummys in my tummies!"

Popping over to the two of them, I quickly and gruesomely devoured every last piece of their bodies before they even had a chance to react! Gosh, this is so much more fun than waiting around with that pansy-ass little loser! I thought he'd be something cool and maybe put up a good fight but he couldn't take even ONE slightly serious attack! What a weakling.

As I watched the people run away from me, I stared back at the door that was swung open in that wide field. Nothing surrounded it, it had kind of just poofed into thin air.

"I just love getting some fresh air and exercise!" I yelled with glee, as I launched myself at another group of nearby snacks.

Part 054: Athelticism

Forty-seven... forty-eight... forty-nine... fifty!

I gasped for breath as I heaved my chest in and out. Training is not fun. I'd never really trained or worked out in my life. I always just kind of 'existed' when it came to my body's health.

Since I arrived in the Labyrinth, I've never taken my body seriously. I kept getting handed spiritual power for free by everyone under the sun, and soon grew haughty because I imagined I was a God. I am not, I am simply a normal everyday man with some lucky, unique, cool abilities.

With that in mind, in order to become a true warrior, I must first master the body so that I can master the mind.

I train now, every day before sunrise. I still am mystified by where the sun comes from, and the room I'm in seems to have no end. No matter how I look at it, it can't be a tiny bubble on my Mental Map. Interestingly, this room itself never seems to move, but outside hallways occasionally shift and meet the main door that leads out into the labyrinth.

And also...

As I did my third lap around the castle, I still felt *it*. When I first arrived in this hell, I felt as though I was being watched. I still feel it. No matter where I go, with my new Detection and Perception abilities, I can definitely feel a gaze trained on me at all minutes and hours of the day. It never stops. I feel it acutely, yet it comes from nowhere.

Who is watching me? Why do they watch? Is it perhaps a game they're playing? Am I a contestant in some strange game they play with new arrivals? Perhaps this is all the work of a great god or demon, they created this hell just to amuse themselves.

I do not know, but someday I will find out.

* * *

After my tenth lap, I stopped completely and fell to the ground. The exhaustion was unbearable. This castle was huge, and running around it took 5 minutes each time. I had managed to run nonstop around it all the time, thanks to casting "*Stamina!*" on myself, but it almost felt like cheating. For sure I'd have dropped before making the first lap without it.

But I don't consider it cheating. I'm simply using my spiritual abilities to enhance my natural ones.

Interestingly, unlike other magic users, my magical effects do not fade over time. If I cast "Enhance" on something, the enhancement is permanent. It doesn't feed off my energy continuously as it would another person's, and it never fades away.

Every morning, when I wake up, I enhance my body as much as possible while still leaving a spiritual energy reserve that allows me to run and do my exercises. I have enhanced myself a dozen times in different areas of the body already. Thanks to some effect of Wisdom King Raphael or perhaps the Crown of Solomon coupled with my perception ability, I can speed up and slow down my perception of time and my body movements at will, and the effect is quite amazing if I don't say so myself.

Still, I'm not getting cocky. I need a weapon and some fantastic armor would make my inevitable voyage back into the maze more sustainable. I could probably just live here in the old territory of Bahamut (Recently renamed to Hero City by its residents!), but I feel restless. These people are living normal lives after their awful entrapment for god knows how long, but I refuse to. I have a purpose and a mission.

Sighing deeply while lying on the grass, I wonder to myself what I should do next. Once I've finished training to a decent extent, what should my next move be?

* * *

Meh, I'll think about it when I get there.

Part 055: Nemesis

"Confidence levels are down 15% since he arrived, and Umi is predicting that if we don't take care of the situation, it'll be a big mess on our hands." Beleth handed out papers to the other demons at the table and then went back to her seat quickly.

Bael sneered. "You're kidding. Initial reports by Beelzebub indicated he's no threat at all. We have nothing to fear. It's hard to even call him a whelp."

Beelzebub quietly smiled his usual barely noticeable edged grin. "I was there, I spoke to him. He's no threat yet, but given time he could be... problematic."

Beleth shifted in her seat. "I'm not saying he is or isn't, I'm merely giving Umi's report. When has she ever been wrong? We got to where we are now because of her. Can't we at least discuss this seriously?"

"Why are we even worrying? The combined power of the Lord of Darkness and the Lord of Flies is more than enough to stop any so-called 'Hero' that may appear. We've squashed dozens in just the last millennium. And even if he got dangerous, it'd hardly take more than a couple Dukes to put him out of his misery." Bael threw his hands up in exasperation. "You fools always do this. Every time a hero appears, you act as if the labyrinth will collapse in a week if we don't put the situation to rest. I'm getting bored. We do more paperwork and tap our fingers more to pass the time than we get to have fun."

A few other board members nodded their heads. Bael was an off-the-cuff speaker, but as one of the top 7 Demon Kings, his word held some sway.

President Ose cleared her throat. "Ahem! Well I certainly worry about it, even if the men here are all gung-ho to go out and fight. I can certainly understand the feeling but let's not do anything to jeopardize our... *finances*." Her otherwise sweet smile she had up to that point turned into a deadly venomous glare as she aimed it at Bael. He glanced away uncomfortably and zipped his mouth shut. President Ose was in charge of the money, and just so long as nothing disrupted the flow of it, everything was fine in her book.

Diablo stared down the table. As the director and the Third ranking of the three emperors, he held the most power at the table. Of course, one had to have both money, political favor, and raw power to ascend to his level, but even so he was unmatched in all three categories except for the other two emperors above him. "Quiet down, Ose. Nobody is going to do anything rash."

To Beelzebub, he directed his next question. "What do you know of the Hero? I want specifics. Details."

Beelzebub sat calmly, his eyes betraying no emotions. "He has a unique power, which of itself is worrying. His power is weak, but if he gets smart, he could be as much trouble as Joan was. Our best defense is the fact that he's rather... unintelligent.... and he doesn't realize what he possesses."

"Yes, but it's wishful thinking to assume he won't ever figure it out." Beleth indicated the blank monitor at the other end of the room, behind herself at the end of the table, where everyone could see the screen.

She turned the screen on to startling video. Bael immediately reacted, as she knew he would. "You can't be serious. Did the Lord of Flies help him out here?"

Beleth slowly shook her head. "No. He did this all by himself."

Beelzebub's eyes narrowed. "When was this video recorded? When I last saw him, he did not have that much power. Nowhere close."

Beleth indicated the timestamp at the bottom right of the screen. "Five months ago. It was a totally one-sided victory."

Beelzebub, rarely one to show his emotions, suddenly appeared confused. "That cannot be correct. I saw him 5 months ago. His power must have increased overnight. How is such a scale of magnitude possible?"

"Ah. Well, it would seem that he was in possession of one of the rings of the Archangels at this point." Beleth nodded knowingly as a murmur went around the table.

Diablo clenched his fist under the table. "That settles it. Contact the Lord of Flies. She witnessed his power, she can handle him as he is right now. We can't risk another Joan on our hands."

"Ah, about that..." President Ose roused herself back into the conversation once again, a finger playing with her long hair. "Dark Queen Amelia said that she refuses to fight him until he's a challenge. She told me she's... busy."

A universal light shrug went around the table. The feeling of 'ah, it can't be helped' was palpable in the air. "That's fine. Honestly, despite what I just saw, Amelia has good judgement. If he gets stronger, we'll just leave it to her." Diablo waved his hand at Beleth and she turned off the gruesome video. They might be demons, but even they have a limit.

Bael finally spoke again, after being silenced by Beleth earlier. "Ah, Director, if I may, I do have one small request."

Diablo nodded. "Go on, King Bael. Let's hear it."

Bael used his willpower to suppress even a small sadistic smile from appearing. "Might I be allowed to send just one of my lower ranked men? Someone disposable... just to test the Hero..."

Beleth smiled. That Bael... always up to something.

Part 056: Hunted

I made a chopping motion with my hand. Half of my squad split up to circle around the building. "We'll cut him off here." I whispered to my three subordinates.

Sneaking around slowly, at the exact moment we had prepared for, all 6 of us jumped out at the same time, aiming into the alley. The Hero wasn't there.

Shit. How did he escape us? He's so much faster now than he was only a few days ago.

"Above us!" one of the men gave a yell and quickly fired an arrow at the Hero. The Hero moved so fast that it startled me. My eyes could barely even track him. Jumping from rooftop to rooftop, he evaded us easily by getting out of our line of sight.

"Hunter squad two, he's on the roof. Send the birds up there." I spoke into my magic crystal communication device, it had a medium range but could pass through anything, even solid brick and dirt.

"Affirmative." Three men jumped out from behind a nearby shop and quickly climbed up the side of the building, jumping from spot to spot as they climbed. Their agility always impressed me.

"Hero is on the move. Shoot to kill, don't hold back." I raced down the street with my men, following behind the Tracker, an expert trained to follow the magical path of any enemy he has attached a spiritual anchor to.

The tracker's eyes were aimed at the top of the roofs, but suddenly his gaze dropped to street level. "He's on the ground again."

"Damn, he's fast. Already two blocks away." I grimaced. He's making this really hard on us.

"Captain Adams, should we set the dogs on him?" My right flanker directed the question at me.

"Negative. The dogs won't be able to catch him, and they're too valuable to risk. We'll do this ourselves." We kept running after the Hero. He wasn't moving forwards very fast. Perhaps he was toying with us.

Suddenly, one of my men gave a yelp, and was yanked into a back alley. What the hell?! "Johnson! Johnson!" We halted our chase to race back into the alley. Johnson was gone, there was no sign of him.

"Shit. Captain, bad news. There's *three* signals now. They're all in different directions."

What the fuck? Three signals? "How is that possible? Tracker A, Tracker B, can you both confirm?" Tracker A nodded. Tracker B confirmed over the radio.

I turned to Phoebe. Wearing her light armor, she was small and slender. You almost wouldn't even notice she was there. "How is this possible? How can there be three signals?"

"He made clones of himself. Be careful, the clones will be half as powerful as he is, but you know how strong he is." Phoebe confirmed my fears. He is so hard to pin down now.

We rushed down another main street, passing many citizens who were alarmed by our military gear, and the sight of soldiers racing down the streets in the middle of day.

"Keep following the original signal, but keep your eyes out for the clones. I don't want another sneak attack. We can't afford to lose anyone else."

Part 057:

"Goddamn it, he's in the sewers now. He's a slippery little..." The Tracker trailed off before he could finish his sentence with an expletive.

"No, this is good." Phoebe chimed in. "There aren't many entrances to the sewer, and his mobility will be drastically cut down. We can cut him off in there."

I nodded. "It's a sound plan. Put Watchmen at each sewer entrance. Once we go in, erect force fields around the- wait."

I paused. A thought came to me. "Shit, this isn't going to work. He can teleport, can't he?"

Phoebe paused, frustration crossing over her face. "You're right. I forgot. That was my error."

I grimaced but it was a light one. "Don't worry about it. Everyone makes mistakes. Besides, we can erect an anti-spatial-travel field above the sewers."

Phoebe nodded as relief filled her face. "Ah, yes, thank you. I had forgotten."

It was new technology, but Hero City had become a bustling capital of economic growth ever since he freed us from Bahamut. And thanks to all the people who had challenged Bahamut in the past, wittingly or unwittingly, this city had an unusual amount of strong humans and demons in it. They made for great soldiers. Even a small lithe woman like Phoebe was not to be underestimated. Of course, her most valuable asset was intel on the Hero himself, after months spent at his side.

We headed down into the sewers. While we could have climbed down the ladders and entered slowly, we needed all the speed we could get in case of a surprise attack. Ordinarily I would have sent troopers in first, but this time I took the lead.

Leaping into the manhole feet first, I splashed down into the smelly cavern with a soft thud. A small stream of liquids, composed of God-only-knows-what ran past my feet. It was only an inch or two deep so thankfully my boots weren't waterlogged with... debris.

"Where the hell are you hiding..." I muttered to myself. My squad dropped down behind me. "Leave Tracker B on the street, but keep him covered. We'll follow the main host, you guys watch out for those damned clones."

It was dark in the sewers. Very dark. I could barely see anything. Activating my helmet gem, a weird reddish light filled the pathway in front of me.

We were at a disadvantage. Hero didn't use his eyes, he hadn't had actual sight for months. Phoebe had explained to me that he possessed a practically impregnable 360 degree spherical field of view around his body now though, thanks to an ability set he had crafted over the last few months. To call him a formidable foe was dangerous. He wasn't just formidable, he was downright terrifying.

We walked down the pathways, shining our lights left and right, checking each path as Tracker A led us towards him.

"...He's coming this way." Tracker A suddenly halted. Then he jerked backwards. "He's coming fast."

"Get behind me." I whispered this and quickly pulled the Tracker to the back. Seconds passed. Sweat trickled down my back. The long path ahead of us continued for a while, with a left path opening up halfway down.

And then suddenly, I spotted something that chilled my blood. Pure white eyes appeared at the end of the hall. My light didn't illuminate as far down as I would have liked, but the lights were as bright as a signal flare in the darkness.

Hero cocked his head, as if listening for our movements. And then he charged.

Part 058:

"Fire at will! Mark, neutralize him!"

Mark was our squad's capturing expert. Casting a quick spell, he managed to send a spiritual energy net at Hero. Hero tore through it in no time, but it gave just a slight enough pause that two of our men managed to fire sleeping darts at him. The darts struck and Hero noticeably slowed down.

And then suddenly he was here, fighting with an unusual ferocity compared to the last few times we had encountered him, he smashed Mark to the ground, probably breaking some bones. Before he could turn to me, I plunged a knife into his shoulder. He howled with anger as he threw me off him, thought his power was noticeably weaker than expected. And then suddenly, he staggered and fell to the ground, face first.

Phoebe grimaced. "Damn. We were tricked. Hoarhiim isn't here."

I realized my mistake instantly. "Goddamn it, you're right. That's why I only saw his eyes glowing. There was no way to miss him coming if the Orb had been at his side, it would have lit up the entire corridor for sure."

I rushed over to Mark. "Mark! Are you okay? We'll patch you up, son, just hold on."

Mark had an incredibly pained expression. "Ah.... my collarbone... he... he..."

"Quiet down, I get the picture. Phoebe!"

Phoebe rushed over and started casting some low level healing magic. She wasn't a particularly good mage, but for something like this, she could at least relieve the pain. We'd have to heal Mark more thoroughly later.

"Get back outside! Hurry! The other squads are in danger!"

Rushing back to the entrance, I left Mark in the tunnel with one other person. It wasn't safe to go to the surface with an injured man.

When I finally climbed up to the top of the sewers, I was suddenly very suspicious. "Where's Tracker B? He's supposed to be up here?"

Tracker A looked around. With Mark and another squad member in the tunnels, it was only Tracker A, Phoebe, and myself in the area. "I can't believe I'm saying this, but there's nobody else around."

What. "You can't be serious? No other squad members? Where did everyone go?"

Tracker A turned at looked me right in the eyes. "No sir, you don't understand. I don't sense *any other life* in the area."

Part 059:

I stared down at the town below me. It was almost comical how easy I found training nowadays.

I watched as captain Adams gave out orders, splitting his squad off, following me into the sewers, and thinking he had me pinned.

I could have almost been amazed at the Tracker's ability to follow three of me at once, but there's just one problem. All three of them were my clones.

I had simply erased my presence completely with a powerful chant of the "Hide!" spell. Setting my clones to "autonomous", they were mindless machines. They had my intelligence, but not my personality. I could experience everything in real-time and if they died, I gained all their knowledge.

While Adams was traipsing around in the sewers, chasing after one of my clones, I sent the other two off to pick off the rest of the squad. By casting "Jammer" I had sealed off their communication and prevented them from speaking with each other. Had he simply tried radioing back, he would have immediately detected the jamming. Adams still has much to learn.

And now, he was comically caught in my 'Illusion' spell, thinking that he and his squad were somehow the only people in the city. Get real! I'm pretty strong now, but not THAT strong! I just altered their perception of the world so that all life appeared to be gone.

Look at him, sweating and panting, he has no clue what's going on. Is he even learning? I try something new every time we have a training exercise, but at this rate I'm doing all the teaching and none of the learning. This is supposed to be for my benefit!

* * *

Teleporting myself down to the battlefield, I appear right in front of the squad. My Illusion magic is so effective though that they don't even see me there.

"Watch out..." whispered Adams. "He could be anywhere."

Yeah, I sure can! Like, maybe, right in front of you!

Walking right up to him and putting my face about two inches from his, I quietly cast a spell.

"Release."

Suddenly, I appear in front of Adams, and he screams in fright and drops to the ground. "Sweet saint Joseph, you scared the daylights out of me, Hero!"

I laughed. "Ha ha ha! You were only following my afterimage the whole time. Are you even trying to learn?"

Adams lowered his head. "Ah, sorry, I guess I really am still just a novice. Compared to your incredible power... I just can't help..." his voice dropped off. Shit, now I feel guilty.

"Calm down, captain. Lemme go heal Mark real quick, and we can get a drink, all right?"

"All right." He seemed to be relieved that we were off the subject. Whatever, I'll talk to him later, see if maybe I can spruce up those leadership juices. Right now, he's the best candidate to run this place when I leave, but I can't leave him as the leader if he doesn't know how to watch over the people with power and caring.

Jumping down the ladder into the sewers, I walk over to Mark and the other soldier.

"Joseph, good to see you. Let me heal Mark now."

Joseph nodded and stepped aside. I grabbed onto him and Mark and teleported ourselves to the surface. There, I healed Mark back to perfect in seconds.

"Alright lads, let's go and get something to drink. It was a good run today."

Part 060:

I felt a little annoyed, when I saw the condition Mark was in. It was easily fixed of course, and yes the simulated combat should feel real enough to draw out every squad member's latent potential, but *still*. My clone was very vicious, I thought I told it not to kill anyone? This technically wasn't killing but the power put into its punch could have done more than break a collarbone, if it hit the wrong spot.

No use worrying about it. A few hours after we went out for drinks, I was back in the castle, sitting by myself in my now official royal bedroom.

My hand rested on the pouch holding Hoarhiim. Still no word from him. Why was he dormant? Was there anything I could do for him? Perhaps not. Maybe, given time, he will revive himself. I still sensed his spiritual life so he wasn't dead...

Again, no point worrying about it. I came here to probe inside the powers of the Crown of Solomon as I had done for many weeks now. It's been 7 months since I entered this labyrinth, and only a couple of those were spent greatly increasing my abilities, yet I already felt incredibly powerful. I'm probably strong enough that there's nobody in Hero City who can be my match.

I thought about Hero City. It was truly massive. It was at least 50 miles in diameter, with over 40 million people packed inside it, living here and there. There were some spaces for parks and tree groves, but overall the composition of the place was that it had a lot of citizens in it. *All of these people had challenged Bahamut to answer her riddle and failed.* The thought still boggled my mind.

But even more interesting, this city *looped*. If you walked far enough in any direction, you would eventually arrive back at your original destination. To be honest, the whole thing reminded me of a tiny planet or something.

There was only one entrance/exit to the Labyrinth, that was the door I had entered through. When I had first seen it, it seemed impossibly big and heavy. What was the point of a door of that size anyway? But now I understood. It was not only to keep the people inside stuck so they couldn't leave, but also to keep unwanted enemies out. This was a human city, and even when it was filled with humans turned into monsters, it was still quite a bit weaker than the enemies in the labyrinth outside. Now that people had reverted to their original forms, only people who were originally Heroes or especially strong could be considered strong enough to combat the demons from Hell. And even then, if they couldn't handle me... well... yeah.

I had stationed a small rotating platoon at the front door... just in case. Now that I was planning to move on, it was a matter of arranging the details so that my work would be completed without me. The Castle was almost self autonomous at this point, the servants there had already developed a hierarchy within that seemed to work well enough. It was already becoming a typical rabble-house of people clamoring for power over one another, trying to rule as kings and dukes and such. Sad, really. Humanity was very predictable once we gathered in large enough groups.

But very soon, I would take my leave, and they would be left to their own devices. Will anarchy ensue? Who can know.

The only things left to attend to were my own personal matters. I had decided to leave Phoebe here. I planned to instate her as the co-ruler. She would make for a kind and compassionate counterpart to Captain Adams' strong-handed and gruff approach. The two would balance each other out. And who knows, perhaps later on, a romance? Ah, I'm getting a little too conniving for my own good. I should stop playing God and focus on myself.

The door awaited. Soon, I would heed its invitation and make my way back into the dark pits of Hell.

Part 061:

The legends were true. We had all but forgotten the horrors of those dark times, more than a thousand years ago. We told bedtime stories to our children about the Great Monster of the past that devoured little kids who didn't do as mom and dad said, but it was all in jest to give them a fright.

But those stories about the Dark Witch... they were true. She had returned.

I slouched in my chair at the Great Hall. As king of Trandor, the largest and mightiest city in the world of Valenzi, I held much power in my grasp. Seven of my ten finest generals were present and briefing me on the current situation. The other three... well, they had already perished awful, indescribable deaths.

"Her rampage continues unchecked." Roland, the highest ranked general pointed to a spot on the map, indicating her last known position, as he concluded his remarks. "The death count is... is... it's in the ah, thousands."

An oppressive aura hung over the room. Our greatest champion, the mightiest of the 10 generals, had met her in hand-to-hand combat. He fought admirably, but in the end, she had shown she was merely toying with him. There was nothing left of his remains that we could identify. How courteous of her to allow a messenger to flee to deliver news. She must have planned for it to sow terror among us.

Gradius spoke next. "I just can't fathom... she eats and she eats, and yet she never has her fill. How can such a small... how can she not tire of the chase..." His words could have almost sounded a joke, but his expression was ashen. He had lost his wife to the evil monster.

I reached over and placed my hand on his back. I could do no better to comfort him. There was no comfort for the living. "General Gradius... you will have your chance at revenge. We must... we must find a countermeasure to her. When the time comes, I will let you strike the final blow."

General Heifl hesitantly spoke, probably to counter my statement. "Ah, King Brand, that won't be- I mean to say... it's not that we don't have any, but we should certainly not seem to have the, ah, ability to fight her..." He trailed off, nervously swallowing as he looked away from my gaze.

I stared at the large map that took up the great table in front of me. Red dots of varying sizes marked the estimated death tolls in areas she had struck, as well as giving an idea of her warpath's direction.

"She appears to be... heading this way." I stated the obvious, as her path was only slightly curved away from us, likely to aim at varying population centers along the route.

"Why has she returned? The lady Joan appeared, according to legend, and told us that she had stopped the Dark Witch's rampage by sealing her in a prison. How had she escaped?" Roland spoke his thoughts out loud, not actually asking anyone in particular.

Lafone, another of my top generals, shrugged. "Who knows? She likely had help from some evil entity."

I nodded. Only a monster of true evil would have freed such a demonic being. What else could have freed her, knowing the hell she had put our people through?

Roland spoke again. "More interestingly, a survivor from the initial village, terrified though she was, gave an eyewitness testimony regarding the appearance of the Dark Witch."

I perked up. "Oh? And what did she speak of?"

"Ah, well, it was rather bizarre. She said that out of nowhere, a large doorway appeared in the middle of her village's wheat field, and a door flew through the air, crushing several people. She survived by crawling under the door and hiding from the Witch's line of sight." Roland shook his head. It sounded absurd. A door that appeared out of nowhere? The woman must have gone mad after seeing the demon go on a rampage.

I stared at the map. It was a long shot. A very long shot. But maybe... just maybe...

"Sir Roland. You are our second mightiest fighter that is left in the capital. Gradius will stay here to evacuate our people. I want you to take an elite squadron and circle around the long route to that door. If it still exists, enter it. This may be our last hope. There exists no champion among our people that can save us now."

My hands were trembling with fear. I hid them under the table. Roland may be our second mightiest fighter, but he was our top general. Losing his battle instincts and ability to command would surely guarantee our world a loss if we should face that demon in the capital. But he was also our only hope if he had to enter whatever place she came from. He alone was the only one I could trust to make it out and come back in one piece.

Roland slowly nodded, as he bit his lip. I was surely sending him to his death. Even so, he also knew that no matter what, if he stayed here, he would surely perish by the Dark Witch's hand.

"Agreed. I would rather chance a slim hope of finding a way to defeat the Dark Witch than simply wait for death to take me."

Roland rose, and pointed to Todoro, the lowest ranked general at the table. "Todoro, you will come with me. Your speed is unmatched. You can run faster than the fastest horse and you do it without tiring. If I should perish, you *must* return and deliver news of whatever is within that door."

Todoro nodded vigorously. To be granted such an important mission, it might be our last chance to save our people.

I rose, and following me, so did all of the other generals.

"Excellent. We will await your return with bated breath." I turned to Lafone. "General Lafone. It pains me to ask this of you. I want you to... to... evacuate the capital city, and prepare a caravan. We must flee the Dark Witch. She may destroy our city, but I shall not allow her to murder my citizens."

Lafone nodded. "Your will, my hand."

Part 062: Roland

I've always considered myself a warrior. A mighty man. A man with nerves of steel.

Yet here I am, cautiously entering a magical doorway into the heavens only knows what evil place. My sword is held firmly in my two hands, yet my hands are sweating and my knees are slightly shaking.

Before we even entered, we could see inside the doorway. A dark, foreboding hallway presented itself. Cautiously walking around the backside of the door, we were stunned to see that the door vanished from view if seen from the rear. I reached my hand through it from the visible side, and it passed through effortlessly. No spell was placed to forbid entry.

What if this was her plan? Maybe she left the door open so that her minions she had left behind would devour anyone who entered. The thought of some demon jumping out and devouring me was making my usual confidence crumble. I left two troopers of the ten I had brought with me behind to guard the doorway at our world's side. Wherever this led to, if the way closed, they would at least be able to ride back and inform the king of what had happened.

Cautious. That's how I would describe myself. I was famed as the world's greatest military leader, having commanded many famous recent battles, including the battle of One Thousand Terrors, where we successfully defended against a large group of irregular monsters, the majority of which were Orcs. I had only taken the safest possible route to victory, however, as I always did. By placing my men's lives as the highest priority, we always fought long battles of attrition and wore the enemy out, then surged to a final major counterattack and seized victory. It had won me over a dozen medals in many different conflicts. At 40 years of age though, I was beginning to tire of the military lifestyle.

"General Todoro... if we should survive this expedition and somehow beat back or defeat the Dark Witch... remind me to permanently retire."

Todoro smirked. "As if. You can play the worrywart, but your heart will always lie on the field of battle."

I nodded apprehensively. It would seem that I may never escape the hells of war.

* * *

Entering the doorway with my 7 soldiers and General Todoro, we were immediately struck by the *smell* of the place. It smelled like dirt, but very bloody and death-filled dirt. I ran my

hand along the closest wall. It was indeed a very smooth earthen texture. Where the devil have we found ourselves?

Todoro held his torch up as we walked. We couldn't see far ahead. The blinding light of our world was growing distant behind us. The hallway had many paths that veered off to the right and the left, but as we had no idea where we were going, we simply kept following the main path, however it turned and twisted. Soon, the doorway to our world was out of sight, and out of mind.

Some time passed, as we silently walked forward, making the least possible noise that we could. There was shockingly little life here. We spotted one rat at some point, which had made a noise in the dark and made my heart skip a beat as terror nearly seized me. Truly, the highest ranking general of Trandor, getting bloodshot eyes over a fist-sized rat... what had the kingdom come to?

Finally, we entered a small room. This room had ominous blue-colored torches lit in its four corners. For some reason, it had a two benches that faced a table in the center of the room, and three other paths that branched forwards, left, and right. Counting the direction that we had just came from, that made four paths.

Curiously, only one of the paths was through a door. It was a small wooden door, off to our right. The other paths were open, though we could not see far down either way.

Cautiously entering the room, one of our troopers carefully stepped around, checking for traps. Finding none, we warily rested our weary bodies on the benches, though we sat facing away from the table, towards the various pathways where an ambush could come from.

"This is truly an evil place." Todoro quietly spoke, breaking the unspoken rule of silence we had maintained all the way to this point. "Nothing lives here, yet somehow that demon came from this world. What place is this to have spawned such an evil child?"

I slowly shook my head, while facing the doorway we had come from. "I know nothing. I am as clueless as you are. This place is truly a nest for demons."

One of the men suddenly sat up straight. His entire body went stiff as he cocked his head listening for something. All of us sensed his movement and immediately stiffened, a couple of the soldiers silently rose to their feet, bodies alert.

Seconds passed. I slowly glanced at the soldier. "What do you hear, Peter?"

His voice was trembling when he replied. "I... I... I think I hear... footsteps. In the distance."

He suddenly turned towards the door. "From... there." He slowly raised a trembling hand towards the door.

We all listened carefully. At first, I heard nothing. But then again, Peter had incredible hearing. He would not lie about such a thing. I trusted his judgement about this. All of us quickly and silently stood up, facing the door. I kept peeking behind us at the open hallways. "If something evil comes through that door. We must flee from the direction we came. Do I make myself clear?" I whispered urgently at the others. Peter was shaking with an incredible fear.

"G-general... there are a lot of f-footsteps coming."

Finally, I heard it. Click-clack, click-clack, like the sound of bones scraping on metal.

BOOM!

The door shook as something slammed into it.

BOOM!

Whatever it was, it was trying to break through!

"RUN!" I yelled, as my men and I fled out the exit we had entered through. From behind us, the sounds of the door crashing onto the ground made a resounding *boom* in the distance as we fled further back into the tunnels whence we came.

And more ominously, we only heard the sound of those dreadful footsteps. They were following us, and they were running fast.

Part 063: Chase

Gasping for breath, we ran faster than we'd ever ran before. I sent Todoro ahead of us, since he could run tirelessly faster than any other man I'd ever met. Being blessed by the Wind God as a child had been of great benefit in his life.

As my men and I fled we were shocked to see Todoro run back towards us after a couple minutes as he rejoined our small troop and started running in step with us.

"Bad news, Roland. I can't believe I'm saying this but the way up ahead is different from the way we entered."

I cursed under my breath. "Damn... we must have entered the wrong path in our haste! Then we must make a stand here in this small corridor. If we get surrounded we will surely die."

Todoro shook his head. "No, General, you misunderstand. This is the correct path. I believe that this place somehow *changed* and the walls have moved or something."

I suddenly felt unnerved. More so than I was before at least. We have a small army of... *something* chasing us in the distance, and it would appear that we've entered some cursed maze of shifting corridors and unknown dangers. Todoro was a brilliant general, not as famed as I am, but definitely quicker witted. He had won his engagements through rapid fire tactics to keep the enemy on their toes and overwhelmed until the very end. While I did boast a 90% survival rate of my troops, he boasted that all his major skirmishes had been completed in a day or less.

To hear Todoro say that this place was somehow shifting... it made no sense, but neither did a doorway appearing out of thin air. "Prepare for combat, we'll keep moving and find a narrow space we can defend from more easily."

* * *

It's been 15 minutes, we went from a familiar set of twists and turns to a completely unknown set of twists and turns. The earthen walls are all starting to look the same. My men and I, except for Todoro, are beginning to get exhausted. At this rate, if we go on much longer, not only will we be forced to stop, when they catch up to us, we'll be too exhausted to fight properly.

"H-halt!" I gasped aloud, and the company slowed to a standstill. "This.... hah.... this is it. We will make our stand here."

The men nodded, as they wheezed and gasped. Todoro, bless his saintly soul, breathed evenly. "If they arrive before you've all regained your energy, I will try to slow them down, even if just for a moment. I swing my sword nearly as fast as I run, you know."

I nodded. He was a one-man army when it came to a fight against many weak opponents. His weakness was singular strong opponents like me. The problem is, we didn't know *what* was chasing us. If they were weak, he might just win by himself. But if they were strong...

"An admirable goal, but if all of us perish here, the King will never know what lies inside this maze. You must go on forward by yourself. My men and I..." I quickly gazed around at the faces of my soldiers. Defeat clung to the air, as they readied themselves to die. Peter had closed his eyes and was praying to our seven divine goddesses for courage, whispering his prayer quietly under his breath as he clasped his hands together.

"My men and I will hold them off. You must escape, Todoro. If this maze has an end, you are the only one who will find it on this day."

Todoro stared into my eyes. A debate raged on in his head. I had not stated this was an order. I outranked him and could surely order him if needed. But... even I did not truly wish to send a single man alone into this hell. If he was to go, it would be due to his own choice.

The sounds of footsteps once again grew loud behind us. Tears filled Todoro's eyes as he bit his lip. "General Roland. It... it has truly been an honor to serve under you." He grabbed my shoulder and gripped it fiercely. "Give them hell."

And with that, he ran down the corridor.

My eyes also filled with tears as I turned to face the monsters chasing us.

Part 064: Confrontation

I ran faster than I'd ever run in my life. The corridors were alien and unknown to me. The sounds of a fierce battle grew distant behind me, as I wiped away my tears.

If I ever survived this, I would never be able to forgive myself for leaving our most famed general behind to face those monsters alone. I could never allow myself to see the honor of medals or ceremonies ever again. When next I fought, it would only be to redeem myself for the tragic sin of leaving behind my commander and fleeing the field of battle.

Of course, I had been told to leave, but it was no order. It could hardly be called an excuse. I know nobody at home would blame me, but I would blame myself. I will always blame myself.

Running down the corridors, I began to feel a sense of hopelessness overwhelm me. I was only guessing which direction to go. Sometimes the path went up, sometimes it went down.

I slowed to a halt as I entered a rather large room. It had crumbled bits of marble and rock scattered on the ground, as the remnants of a smashed statue's remains had been littered everywhere. At my feet, there lay a great golden door. Unbelievable in its size and weight. If this was truly solid gold, it would have been worth a thousand treasures.

All around me, the signs of a battle fought long ago. Skeletons littered the ground, likely decayed and rotted from whatever distant past they had come from. Strangely though, none of these skeletons were wearing clothes. Had their remains been looted by whomever the victors were? I knew not.

Different paths opened up around me. Across from me, a large doorway, the doors themselves missing, sat ahead of me. I assumed that must be the place these incredible doors had once barred. Whatever had sent them flying, it must have been incredibly powerful.

To my right and left there were two other open pathways. I knew not which pathway, if any, would lead me to salvation or despair. It was hopeless. This maze grew only more consuming as I made my way down its paths. There could be no escape from this hell. I bitterly stifled my emotions as I realized I had left my General behind to die alone pointlessly. I might as well have died fighting alongside him, and died with honor.

I sat down on the steps and took a swig of my small ration of water. This was all I had left. To increase my speed, I had left much behind. I had no food, only a small bit of water, and no hope to escape this maze. If I was lucky, I would die to starvation and dehydration rather than the demons that infested this place.

As I sat there, I noticed something curious, out of the corner of my eyes. One of the skeletons, buried underneath the door, but sticking halfway out, it seemed to be moving. I immediately leaped to my feet in alarm. Shit! Of course, these were not the remains of humans! These were reanimated undead creatures, likely summoned by necrotic energies. My alarm slowly faded though as I realized the skeleton could only shift its weight a bit here and there. It slowly turned and cocked its head at me, and instead of trying to shift towards me, it seemed to be trying to *get away*.

The skeleton clawed at the ground, trying to pull itself free and head in the direction of the path to my right. As I pondered this, my heart suddenly stopped as I heard a voice from behind me. The voice was deep and gravelly, almost animalistic in tone.

"A human?"

My body began shaking and my breath slowed to almost a standstill as I slowly turned around to face the thing that had asked the question.

From behind me, in the distant darkness, I saw a demon. A silhouetted demon with two bright white glowing eyes.

Part 065:

The demon walked towards me slowly. I started to back up, but paused, realizing that I should not show fear in front of a singular monster.

As it drew closer to me and my torch, I slowly stopped shaking as I realized it was simply a muscular young man, perhaps 20 years of age. He had long blonde hair, it draped down past his shoulders. He wore a golden crown, and white armor that seemed to be made out of some fantastic metal I couldn't pinpoint. Strangely, despite being a resident of this hell, he wielded no weapon.

The young man walked towards me. I noticed that his bright white eyes, though possessing no pupils, seemed to be staring at the ground as he walked. "Lower your weapon. I mean you no harm."

I didn't really wish to comply, but something about the man screamed that I should not attempt to fight him, as not only was it pointless and I seemed sure to lose, but he did not seem to be my enemy. "Who are you?"

The man paused as he stared at the ground. "I am... just a traveler. I live in this labyrinth as I must now do so."

I nodded. The man had clearly seen battle. His armor, though pure white, was covered in various scratches, dents, and scuff marks. "It's good to see another face here. My name is General Todoro. It is good to meet you, traveler."

The man suddenly held up his hand at me. "Do not give out your name so easily in this place. Your true name can be used to curse and hex you by all manner of foul beasts."

I swallowed and nodded. "Of... of course, thank you for the warning. I shall be sure to heed it."

The traveler smiled. It was a thin, wispy smile, barely even there. One could confuse it for a slight curving of the lips. "It's been a long time since I saw another human. Almost a year, in fact. Why are you running around here? Do you have a death wish?"

I slowly shook my head as I gazed at the floor. "I come from a country, or a world, or... some place. I entered this maze with my companions, we had to find the source of the Dark Witch's power. She has killed many of my countrymen, and she threatens the existence of my people."

The man slowly nodded. "Dark Witch, you say? Could you describe her for me?"

"Yes. She wears a black dress, has a dark sword at her waist, and she carried a black orb in her left hand. She is small, one could almost confuse her for a small child if she were not such a ferocious demon. She has long black hair and wears a blood red ribbon in it." I described her appearance, and as I did, the traveler slowly stiffened.

"It can only be Amelia. Why is she attacking humans? So strange. I had not thought her to be one who would do such a thing. Where is she now?" He waved his hand in the air, making various motions, almost as if manipulating some invisible object.

I shook my head again. "I don't know. Wherever my kingdom is, she is there. I cannot find it. The path has changed too many times."

He nodded knowingly. "Yes. You are trapped in a shifting maze of shadows and deceit. Only one with a pure heart can lead the way." He smiled at me wryly. "Or, one with a map. I have such a thing."

I narrowed my eyes, feeling perplexed. "A map? How can one make such a thing? Would a map not be useless in a maze that changes shape?"

He nodded. "I have a special map, it's only visible to me and it shows me a great many things. I have used it to track prey, escape down hidden paths, and plot my way towards my eventual destination."

I nodded quickly. "I see! Very useful! And where might you be headed?"

His unseeing eyes slowly curved up towards me as he stared into my eyes. "I'm heading towards the bottom. The very bottom of these Pits of Sheol."

Part 066:

"Are you a mighty warrior?" I asked, tentatively.

"Not really. I'm less of a warrior, and more of a... magician." The man grinned as his eyes seemed to rove over his own body. "Not exactly a pure mage or anything, more of a hybrid." His smile widened even more as he chuckled at some joke that I did not understand.

"If... if you are strong, maybe you could help me. Help my people, I mean..." I struggled to find words. I honestly did not want to ask an outsider to fight that horrifying witch on behalf of my people. I might as well have asked him to hurl himself into a volcano.

The man shook his head. "I will not help you or your people. However, Amelia is someone I am familiar with. I will confront her for my own selfish reasons."

He paused, and cocked his head somewhat. "By the way, you mentioned companions. You said you left them behind. Where are they now?"

I glanced behind him. "Somewhere in the direction you came from. By now the path has surely changed... I don't think I could lead you back to them."

The traveler shook his head. "No, that won't be necessary. Give me a moment." His hands furiously manipulated the unseen map in front of him. "Ah, there appears to be a large mass of life forms in this direction." He pointed to the room at the right. What? To go back to my companions, we have to go *forwards*? This place is truly a labyrinth that cannot be solved.

He finished manipulating the map and started immediately walking towards the right pathway. Quickening his step, he suddenly paused, making me stumble forwards and halt to catch my balance. Looking down at the struggling skeleton, who was now frantically clawing at the ground, he smiled another wispy grin. "So, one of you still lived, eh?"

Raising his hand up, he aimed it at the skeleton. I leaped back in alarm, as he suddenly said "Explosion!"

BOOM, the ground underneath him and the skeleton evaporated, as debris flew all over the room. What the hell was that? He shot some kind of energy blast out of his hands. Was this why he didn't require a weapon? I had seen magic before, the most powerful mages in the land lived in the Kingdom's capital. However, they were a drop in the bucket compared to what I'd just seen from him. The most powerful wizard that had lived nearly 200 years ago, Archimedes, had been able, after a day of conjuration, to summon a windstorm that drove out barbarians from

the lands they had invaded. When it was all said and done, that was his final great act, and he passed away due to exhaustion and spiritual overload.

And when it all came down to it, I now believed I am witnessing a man who could easily best Archimedes in a magic duel. He had cast his spell so fast and efficiently that I don't think it even affected him. Archimedes had always taken time to cast any spell of any large magnitude, and it always took a toll on him. He died at the young age of 35, but his body had aged like he was over a hundred. His skin had hung off his bones, drooping like butter scraped over too much bread.

As I followed the traveler down the pathway towards my comrades, I began to feel hope again. Yes, this one, he might be able to save us. If he fought the Dark Witch, he might just have the strength to put an end to her reign of terror.

He might even be hailed as a hero, just like the holy hero, Joan of Arc.

Part 067:

As we rounded corners, I found myself having doubts. Certainly, the man in front of me, leading the way, was strong. But was he strong *enough*?

We were going to be facing an unknown horde of enemies. They could be skeletons, orcs, I don't even know what! And it's two guys, just him and I! I know he's probably strong, but perhaps by following him, I've made a dreadful mistake.

And what about his eyes? Those inhuman, demonic glowing eyes. Any smart man would stay away from such a terrifying face, yet I'm about to trust he's just willing to save a random stranger and his comrades for no reason? There must be an ulterior motive.

"Hey, I have a question." I said, as we kept running forwards. I was impressed with his speed. He wasn't just keeping up with me, he surpassed me. I was having trouble keeping up with *him*.

"What's up?" The Traveler asked me, nonchalantly. What a strange manner of speaking.

"Ah, well, it's just... your eyes, how are they glowing like that?"

The man slowed down a little as he rested his hand on his face. While still running full speed, he was perfectly able to see somehow, even with his hands blocking his eyes. "Ah, well, that is due to a certain happening a year ago. It involved an old man and a lion."

I think he is fooling around with me. I decided not to inquire deeper.

"We're here." The man said, as we slowed to a halt and started slowly inching forwards to peer into a doorway.

At the end of the hall, signs of a fearsome battle that had taken place were everywhere. Bodies lay on the ground, all of which were from monsters. My chest was thumping hard as I visually scanned for human forms. I saw none.

"Perhaps they... they may have survived?" My question was less an inquiry and more a hope spoken aloud. Stepping over the carcass of a massive... beast... we continued onward slowly. I glanced back over my shoulder at the thing. It had a long trunk, resembling an elephant, but a mouth full of vicious looking sharp teeth, and dead red eyes. It was some kind of abomination.

Skeletons crowded the path as we pushed forwards. Some were still moving, and the Traveler easily put an end to those, though he used more quiet methods than that Explosion chant he had used earlier.

It still boggles my mind. *Instant casting*. Unheard of, nobody could do it instantly. Perhaps he was a warrior monk from a distant land, using some power of Ki or some other thing. I didn't know, but he was certainly interesting.

Suddenly the traveler halted, as did I. "Up ahead. Humans."

Hope blasted into my heart. I didn't know how he knew they were up there, but surely it was them. "How many?"

He paused for a second. "Seven. They're all dead."

My hope instantly vanished and was replaced with horror. "No... no... it can't be..."

Dashing forwards, I raced down the hall. I arrived at a junction where it ended at a wall, and a path going right and one going left. At the junction were 5 bodies. None of the 5 were Roland. But off to the side, just around the corner to the right... Roland and Peter lay.

"No... I can't... it was my fault..." I fell to my knees as tears formed. "I failed them... I failed them all..."

"Hold. This one, he's still breathing." The Traveler walked over to Peter. I leaped to my feet and dashed the few remaining feet and grabbed hold of Peter's hand. It was still warm. Blood covered his chest and body. His shoulder pads were ripped off, his arms dislocated. His head was gashed, bloodied, and bruised. Whatever had hit him, it had hit him hard.

And as for General Roland... he was in a gruesome state. It burned me with rage to see how the monsters had defiled his body. I dare not describe it with words, the sight was simply too horrifying. I only knew it was him because of the purple armor he wore and the emblem on his chest signifying his rank. His head was no longer attached, it was completely missing.

Turning back to Peter, I spoke quietly to him. "Peter... Peter... can you hear me?"

At first, nothing happened. Then blood drooled out of his mouth as he turned his head in my direction. "Ah... Todoro... you came back for us... have you saved... the others..." he wheezed as he spoke, the sound of a punctured lung. He likely had terrible internal bleeding.

I stared into his lifeless eyes. He could no longer see anything. But he could still speak. "Yes. Yes... I managed to save them. They are..." I turned back to look at the bodies behind me as tears welled up. "They are resting now. They are very tired from the fight..."

Peter smiled. It was a faint smile, one that showed he could no longer feel the immense pain plaguing his body. His brain had likely started shutting down. "Good... I'm glad you... you could make it back in time... but I won't be going with... you... tell m- tell my wife..."

He coughed quietly as more blood drooled out. The traveler stared unemotionally at him. Distantly. In the back of my mind, I thought to myself *he sees a fellow human dying and feels*

no emotion, he is truly a heartless monster.

Peter was unable to finish his sentence. His strength was leaving him too quickly. "It... hurts... it... hurts... so dark..."

The traveler suddenly seemed to get a snarling expression on his face. "All right, I've had quite enough of this. I don't usually interfere, but I hate long goodbyes."

He reached his hand up and aimed it at Peter. I felt shock in my body as I realized what was coming. That's the exact same pose he used on the skeletons!

"NO!" I screamed as the traveler started to open his mouth.

"Heal!"

...Huh?

Part 068: Loss

Peter stared at the corpse of General Roland. "He was there for me the whole time. It was his sacrifice that let me be among the living now."

He slowly turned and his eyes glossed over as he saw the bodies of all his comrades. "Well... you were right. They are resting now. At least they will be at peace in the bosom of the 7 goddesses."

I nodded. "Can you tell us what happened?"

Peter grimaced as the memories came flooding back. "It was... overwhelming."

* * *

"General! They're coming!" Dmitri, the front guardsman, turned his square shield towards the horde of skeletons racing towards us. I pulled out my bow and arrow and started firing as fast as I could. My arrows barely seemed to be doing any damage though.

"No! Use a crushing weapon! Get a mace or use the flat side of your sword!" Roland cried out. I didn't know why he said this, but he spoke correctly. Rushing forwards, I started striking the skeletons on the head with the flat side of my sword, and their bones caved in like a knife cutting through a soft cake. But slashing them seemed to be ineffective.

Richard, our only magician, but a talented mage as it were, began casting an anti-undead spell. "Hold them off! I will prepare Searing Light!"

"Understood!" Screamed the four men holding off a horde of more than a hundred tightly packed skeleton warriors. I was among those men.

A full minute passed. "Richard!!! The spell! Is it ready?!" I screamed back at him, as I deflected another skeleton sword that I stopped inches from beheading me.

I somehow spared a quick glance back. Richard was panting with exhaustion as he prepared what was likely the most powerful spell of his life. I didn't expect a verbal answer, I just wanted to communicate how dire our situation was. Lucas had already taken a bad hit and Jeremiah had pulled him back and taken his spot. With Richard not only focused on his massive spell, but the fact that he would likely be too exhausted afterwards, Lucas was the likeliest to die first.

"Hang in there, soldier! Don't you dare die on me and leave that beautiful wife of yours alone with your son!" Roland roared at him as he charged and attacked a rather large looking orc that had shoved its way through the mass of enemies and thrown Dmitri and myself to the side. We quickly regained our footing and left the Orc to the General. He could handle it.

Suddenly from behind me, there was an insanely bright light, it blinded us temporarily which would ordinarily be a death sentence, but for the fact that it was designed to do far worse things to the enemies we were fighting.

"Unholy abominations, in the names of the seven goddesses, begone from this world!" Roared Richard, as he blasted a wave of light from his body. For a split second, he had looked so beautiful, one would be forgiven if they were to think of him as an angel.

The blast didn't just kill the undead, it obliterated them. Normally undead make no noise as they fight other than the sound of their bones or weapons hitting metal. But the instant the light hit them, they *screamed* a delightfully awful scream as whatever poor souls they may have had were evaporated and sent upwards to the goddesses.

And when my vision came back seconds later, the entire hallway was empty. The light had flashed forwards and kept going around the bends and twists for probably a mile around us in all directions. We were safe from the skeletons now.

Turning back around to face Richard as my chest heaved in and out, I watched as he collapsed to the ground. Damn, it took a worse toll on him than I expected. Without our resident bishop, we were on our own when it came to injuries. The General had already slain the orc, and was resting on the ground, sitting on his rump. "Godesses. That was insane. Richard, are you alright?"

Richard laid on the floor, his arms and legs unmoving. His breaths came in the form of ragged gasps. "Hahhhh... yes general, but I'll be- hahhhh I'll be of no use anymore... I need weeks of sleep to recover from... this..." and suddenly his eyes closed, and he was fast asleep. Magic took not just a physical and spiritual toll on him, but a mental toll as well. Casting that one spell to him was like staying awake for two weeks straight.

We quickly got up and dragged his sleeping body over to the wall and laid him there.

"Shit. Damn! Lucas is down too, and without Richard..." Dmitri cursed our luck as he held Lucas' dying body in his hands. "Stay with us! You're a great warrior! You won't die in this world of hell! You must return to your family!"

Lucas slowly shook his head as his eyes started to turn cold. "I never could beat you... in a fair match. This is your win..." and as he said that, his hands slowly dropped to his side and he gave a final sigh as the breath left his body.

Dmitri fought back tears valiantly. "No... I'd rather lose than win... if this is what winning means...!"

"General! M-more are coming!" Jeremiah, the person currently on lookout, rose to his full standing position from his kneeled resting position. Fatigue was evident.

"Curses! It's only been five minutes! We need more time!" I yelled angrily as the realization that another unwinnable fight was upon us hit me.

"Ready yourselves. If these skeletons want a fight, then as warriors of the 7 goddesses, we shall put an end to their miserable existences!" Roland gave a small rousing speech as we all staggered back towards the battlefield, leaving the bodies of our two comrades behind us.

But we were wrong. What came around that corner was no skeleton. It was a *true* monster.

Part 069: (͡° ͜ʖ ͡°)

It's been a good day.

I was able to kill seven filthy insects, I'm now hunting down the eighth one, and everything is going very well. Exactly according to my plans.

I inspected my Rolex. It was 12 o'clock on the dot, exactly as I'd planned.

My plans never failed. I may be 'just' a lowly lord, but I'm smarter than the rest of them. I wear only the finest clothes. I think only the finest thoughts. I am not just refined and elegant, I am perfect in every way. Compared to the demons who think they are above me, I am a perfect being.

Females? I have no time for them. Dainty little creatures that bicker and squabble. Oh how they love my presence. They would do anything to bear my children, but no demon is worth my time. The moment you trust a demon, they will stab you in the back. Of course, I'm no hypocrite. Anyone who trusts me will get knifed as well.

" **Ah, my lord, it is an honor to sssserve under you.** " The Anacondess spoke to me, as I knew she would. Lowly creatures of low intelligence always perform predictable actions. I knew that she couldn't keep her mouth shut for 5 minutes if she thought she could curry some favor with a demon of higher ranking than her.

I ignored her, and her head drifted away, as she realized that I was not interested in conversing.

I turned to the Skeleton Commander I had created many hours ago. "Have you found the other human yet?"

Being incapable of speech, the skeleton shook its head. Perfect, I hate idle chatter.

The Anacondess was still miffed that I hadn't responded, so wanting to avoid any unnecessary... drama... I turned back to her. "Make yourself useful. Use that heat sensing of yours and find the other human. Master's orders."

The Anacondess sniffled a little bit that I had ignored her praise earlier, but heeded my words and went off in search of the human down a different path. Whether she found him or not, I didn't care. If he accidentally managed to kill her, I'd be rid of a small pest. Naturally she had been gifted to me by one of the upper ranked Duke demons, and he always rubbed my nose in it. I didn't even ask for her.

I need nobody's gifts. I will force them to give me things when they realize they have no power over me.

"Lord Beelzebub, we've found trace footsteps in a nearby corridor. We think they went this way." A gruff young demon, someone not even yet of the Lord class, spoke to me.

"Excellent. It took you long enough. Let's go find the last cockroach so I can get back to work in the manor." A Lord's work is never done, even as we plot to climb the ranks of demonic power.

* * *

As we drew closer, I couldn't help but notice that the young demon was staring up at me as we walked side by side with the company of troops following us. When I started to look down at him, he quickly looked forward again, trying to pretend he hadn't just done it. If I were a sentimental demon, I might find it endearing. Right now, I find it sickening.

"Stop staring at me. It's disrespectful and is liable to get you killed." I snapped at him and he immediately stopped doing it.

"Ah, my apologies. I just... I can't believe that you're a lord." The young demon's comment caught me off-guard.

Suddenly coming to a stop, I held a hand up behind me to tell the rest of the monsters to halt. Turning to the young demon, I carefully adjusted my tie, as I held on to the careful and delicate harmony I had cultivated within myself, to take away from my younger days as an anger-prone mistake-ridden youth.

"*Clarify.*" I hissed at him.

"Oh, no disrespect intended my lord, I simply meant that it's unthinkable one such as you could only be of the lord rank. The Council must fear you to limit your advances like so..." His voice trailed off, as he gave a slow hard swallow.

Ah, so that's what he meant by it. Despite what they say, certain kinds of flattery *will* get you everywhere.

"I see." I said simply, as I started walking again. The company behind me jerked forward again as they realized I was moving. If I had a sense of humor, I might find it comical. But I didn't, since I don't.

From around the bend ahead of us, the Anacondess returned and slithered towards us. Perfect, I was thinking I'd like to brutally choke someone to death.

"I've located them, massster Beelzebub." Oh? Apparently she brought good news.

Wait.

"Them? There's only supposed to be one human, you incompetent little-" I raised my hand up to strike her but she quickly spoke again.

"There are three of them now massssster, and one of them isssss of the original sssseven that we killed..."

I stopped my hand in midair, then lowered it back to my side. "Interesting." Somehow we hadn't finished off all of those seven insects. One of them was still alive and kicking. *And* he had made some friends.

This might possibly be the first time my plans have gone wrong. I'll have to make sure it's the last as well.

Part 070: Umi

Humans.

They're weak, pathetic, petty, fragile beings. They fight amongst themselves over anything, they're worse than starving dogs fighting over a bone. They'll do anything to hurt one another.

Some humans can demonstrate a great amount of compassion. Sometimes you can even make humans appear respectable and make them follow a hierarchy. But it's always temporary. It's always transient.

Since I first started observing every being in existence, I've found many things to be true, but the most true is that humans are the lowest of all sentient races.

But... there is a problem with that statement.

As it stands, humans as a whole are completely worthless. Demons are far more powerful, more advanced, more intelligent, and more devoted to tradition and hierarchy than humans are. They understand that might makes right, but also that you have to go through a proper channel. This makes them easy to *control*.

But I fear humans. Not the whole of humanity, but the single individual.

Collectively, humans are weak, but once in a great while, a single human arises. This one human will change everything in an instant. Demons live for ages upon ages, usually dying only if killed by another being. They have the ability to live eternally, just as the angels do, but demons will very often die at some point due to an accident, or a challenge to their rank, or any one of a thousand other possibilities.

But humans only live a short while. Unless they take the power of a demon somehow, they will often die in the blink of an eye. They are born, they live, and they die. Every single human who has ever lived knows this to be true.

But their weakness, their eventual guaranteed death, is also their strength. It is a strange quirk of fate whatever gods may actually exist gave humanity the shortest life span, but also the most unstable bodies. They are the testing ground for all other sentient species. For every 1,000 powerful demons or angels, there only exists one powerful human.

But that human will become a true monster.

And two of those humans have come into recent existence. One perished at the cost of many demon lives, a few hundred years ago. A blink in the folds of time, especially compared to how long I have existed. The other seemed to be born immediately afterwards. I usually have time to

react and sense the presence of a powerful human, but this one simply appeared one day. In *my* labyrinth.

This is my home. It is my domain. It is connected to everything that was and will be. And the human appeared out of nowhere. Where did he come from? I cannot interfere with him directly or indirectly, I can only observe. And observe I do.

This human is going to be a great trouble. He possesses knowledge and intelligence no other human before him has had. He has a terrifyingly unique power. And he's rapidly becoming more adept at using it.

I have to stop him.

I have to kill him.

If I don't he will be the end of me.

Unacceptable.

Part 071: Fright

"It's...him..." Peter spoke weakly, his entire body trembling as he indicated the demon approaching us. "H-h-he killed General Roland.... w-with a single..."

Peter suddenly turned and stumbled away weakly, vomiting on the ground behind himself as his terror overtook him. I'd never seen Peter like this before. He was on the precipice of going mad with fear.

The traveler stared evenly at the approaching demon. And a demon he was. A pure black suit with a black tie, wearing black gloves and black shoes, and an odd looking hat with a brim that circled all around his head, jet black hair darting out from under it in various places. And his eyes... glowing red, burning fiery eyes. One would think that if he grabbed you and stared into your eyes, he could drain the soul from your body with just his burning stare.

"Beelzebub. So you've come. I've been looking for you." The traveler walked forwards slowly, him and the demon, apparently named Beelzebub, coming to a stop about 15 feet from one another. A comfortable distance, a *safe* distance, to be sure. The traveler was strong... but whatever Peter had seen, I feared this demon more than I trusted in the traveler's ability to protect us.

"It's been a while, ' Hero '." The demon spoke down to the traveler, almost like a father chiding a son, but with a large bit of sarcasm and disgust dripping in his ominously deep voice. "I see you're still running around, playing savior with your other insect... friends."

The traveler shook his head. "These are not my friends. I met them only minutes ago." My heart suddenly sunk. Shit... it's hopeless... "But as for you, I do have a bone to pick."

"Oh? Have you been coming after me... just as you did the other ten lords that have gone missing recently?" Beelzebub glared at the hero. "Those were my tools that you disposed of. Useful pawns. I lost much influence because of your actions."

The traveler, or 'hero', shrugged. "Can't be helped. I have to kill all of you demons anyway. You're in my way. And it drew you out, didn't it?" The Hero sneered, a vicious visceral look. "You demons are so... *predictable*."

Beelzebub suddenly flared up as his eyes brightened in intensity. He seemed to be holding back a massive amount of rage. "You... you think you can... *toy* with me? You think you can simply mock me and I'll let you walk away?" Beelzebub slowly began to undo his tie. "Oh... this is going to be... *very* satisfying. Give me a moment, if you will... I need to make sure I don't ruin my nice suit with your *filthy* insect blood."

The hero chortled. "A moment? I'll give you an eon. You've already lost. Maybe you should walk away so I don't send you crawling."

Beelzebub quickly undid his tie. "Child. Take this.... and fold it neatly. *Neatly*." He spit the last word out and the younger demon by his side shuddered slightly as he quickly and gently took the tie from him.

In a flash, Beelzebub had taken off his suit top as well, and his hat. Now he only wore his suit pants and a black long sleeved dress shirt. The man knew how to dress. He looked impeccable with or without his full suit on.

"I'll leave the pants. You don't deserve the sight of what's underneath."

The traveler grinned. "You've developed a sense of humor, haven't you, *Beelzy*." My god. This man was mad. He just mocked a demon. We're going to die horribly.

The demon gnashed his teeth. "Don't you *ever* act familiar with me, insect. If you shorten my name like that again, I'll shorten your life to nothing."

The traveler shrugged again. "Let's be serious now. You were going to do that anyway. Or at least, you were going to *try*." His grin grew ever wider.

The demon's grimace faded, as he closed his eyes. "I'm going to enjoy this far more than I should."

Part 072: Battle Bowl

What the hell am I watching. I can't follow this with my eyes. I can barely follow it at all.

Beelzebub was the first to move. At a speed so fast I almost missed it, he appeared behind the traveler, he stabbed his hand forwards into the traveler's heart.

The traveler instantly died. In fact, he didn't just die, he faded *into dust*.

"Hm?" Beelzebub didn't look happy that he'd won, he looked perplexed, and his eyes started darting around. "Where did you run off to?"

And suddenly, the traveler, no, the *hero* was behind him. With a single slap, he smashed Beelzebub into the wall. "GAH!" Beelzebub yelped as the attack caught him by surprise, but he stood back up a second later. Despite the impact damage to the earthen wall, Beelzebub somehow seemed unharmed.

Beelzebub stood back up and stared warily at the hero again. "Filthy insect. I knew you wouldn't fight me fair and square. Always resorting to simple tricks and deceit." He glanced down at his pants, which were now slightly tattered and very dirty. "Ah... this fills me with such.... anger!"

He lunged again at the hero, and punched the hero right in the chest, or at least he tried to. The hero deflected it with a single hand, the other one reaching around and slapping Beelzebub across the face once more. Curiously, I noted amongst the speed of the battle that the hero never once looked at Beelzebub. He always had his head aimed at the ground. Was he perhaps... blind?

Beelzebub snapped when the second slap hit him. "You insolent little-!" Jumping backwards he unhinged his mouth and I jerked back involuntarily as he suddenly breathed a massive wall of fire. It hadn't reached me yet as I was a hundred feet away, but it blasted down the corridor and would be here in a second.

The Hero reached his hand out. " **Absorb!** "

The fire instantly disappeared. It seemed to suck inside his hand instead of passing all around him. Beelzebub took a step back. "You've changed. I should have realized when my pieces went missing but... I didn't think you had grown to this extent."

Hero nodded. "And you haven't changed. Always underestimating humans. I've heard about what you've done. It all ends today."

Then, something unexpected happened. To be honest, everything here was unexpected, but what happened next blew my mind.

The hero simply said " **Invisibility!** " ... and he vanished.

"Clever." Beelzebub said simply.

Moving his hands quickly, he cast a spell, what the effect was, I'm not sure. "Unfortunately, as a filthy human, your blood runs hot. You can't hide from a predator's vision."

"Let's change that." A voice came out of thin air. " **Reptile.** "

Suddenly Beelzebub was actually visibly confused. "What? You can make your blood cool?! How is that possible?!"

"It really is unfair, isn't it, *Beelzy?*" Said a voice from somewhere in the room. Beelzebub jumped and swung at its source wildly, but only hit the wall. "Always thinking you're so smart and above it all. Your pawns fell, just as you will. You think you're a predator, but I am the real predator here."

Beelzebub reeled as something smashed into his back, then as he flew forward, just before he hit the wall, another impact smashed into his face, sending him flying backwards. But this happened 4 more times, in the space of 4 seconds, he was smashed back and forth by the invisible Hero, who could not be seen or heard as he continued his relentless assault.

"You simply don't understand. I haven't even started getting serious yet. You're finished." Hero spoke again, this time his voice seeming to come from within the walls themselves. I was wrong, this man was the real monster here.

Beelzebub staggered to his knees as he coughed up blood and spit some teeth on the ground. His face, no longer in perfect condition, was hideously beaten and torn up. "Hah... how d-did you?!"

Beelzebub paused as a storm of thoughts crossed over his face. "Ah... now I remember... three archangels..."

"Wrong!" said a voice cheerfully from a nearby invisible spot. "I've had the ability since I first appeared in this hell. Hoarhiim and the archangels only increased my available magic output. But over the last year... I've gained a lot more power than that. I'm probably equal to, oh, say, a Duke class demon? Probably higher to be honest!"

Beelzebub seemed stunned. "Im...possible... you haven't even been here two years... yet... so fast...?"

"Yeah. I really am a walking cheat code." He chuckled to himself at some joke. I didn't know what a cheat code was, but it must have been a fearsome monster.

"By the way, Beelzy, old buddy old pal... you do realize that this was over from the start, right? I only turned invisible to play around a little." Pausing for a second, I suddenly heard his voice right in front of me. " **Visibility.** "

He appeared in front of me, his body now covered in lizard-like scales. Hero yawned and stretched a little. "Well... it was a good run. But unfortunately, you were outmatched from the start. Even if you were incredibly powerful... it would be too easy. I'm sorry, friend."

Beelzebub grimaced as he staggered back to his feet and pointed at the Hero's chest. "This... isn't over. I will return, and when I do-"

The hero raised his hand and his grin disappeared as he stared coldly at the demon. "No, Beelz. You won't return. I already sealed your teleportation before you got here....Farewell." Hero's voice was icy cold.

Then he said a single word, as his hand aimed at Beelzebub.

" **Die.** "

Part 073: Godlike

" *Scientia potentia est.*" I said as I watched the life drain from Beelzebub's face and his body slump to the ground. "Knowledge is power."

A famous man once said those famous three words, and he was correct. Perhaps not in the way that he had meant. For me, a strong vocabulary is my deadliest weapon. The more words I know in my original language, the more power I possess.

For an entire year, I have trained and learned tirelessly. Thanks to the wisdom of Raphael, I realized that I had all the power I ever needed, I simply needed to learn to bring it out. I've fought ten lord demons, and hundreds of lesser demons.

I have yet to fight anything higher than a lord, but suffice to say all the lowest ranked demons are weak. They have a simple assortment of spells that they use, they all breath fire (*yawn*) and, at least for Beelzebub's minions, they all squeak when they're caught. They spill the beans like clockwork. They told me about all of Beelzebub's little mannerisms, his little quirks, how he was fussy and hated to be touched, and how he despised being looked down on. Even if I couldn't kill him with a single word, knowing all his weaknesses made what would have been a potentially formidable foe pathetic.

But I *can* kill with a single word. I can simply tell things to die, and they do.

But that's not all I can do.

Beelzebub's minions stared in horror as their master was defeated with barely any effort, I stifled a huge laugh and kept my face stony so they would be terrified.

"You're next."

They were petrified. Absolutely petrified. They should be, they were facing a filthy *human*, and nothing was scarier than a human with power. Humans feared demons, but demons feared humans *more*. That was the real reason they hunted us down. They wanted to kill us all and prevent Heroes from being born.

Aiming my hand at Beelzebub's cooling corpse, I spoke another word.

" **Puppet.** "

His eyes slowly flared back to life. He rose up once again, his body beaten and battered. He stared unblinkingly ahead, no trace of his original personality existed.

" **Heal.** "

I flicked out my forked tongue, as I watched his body quickly regenerate. If he were still alive, this would be truly agonizing, but he made not even a slight verbal complaint.

"What are your orders, my master?"

I nodded in the direction of his former minions. "Ah, I dunno. Why don't you just go and... take out the trash?"

* * *

We walked down the corridor. Three humans and 11 demons. I had summoned the other 10 demon lords and now they flanked us as they walked, along with Beelzebub. None of them were particularly strong, and I didn't need them for protection or anything seeing as I had a spherical view of every object around me for a mile in every direction... but I just felt like it, you know?

"Beelzebub, what demon in a rank immediately above you do you despise?" I spoke to him. The puppet has to obey all commands and answer all questions the master gives. His minions were pathetic though, I didn't even have to make them into puppets for them to spill the beans. At least he was more refined.

"Ah, I currently hold no opinions on any other demons due to my lack of a personality, however I previously loathed Mephisto and Bael." I stared into his unblinking, almost robotic gaze. Did he just joke around about his personality? I must have imagined it. "Mephisto is a mid-ranked duke but he holds a vast amount of political influence. Bael is the most powerful of the top ranked 7 kings. I advise not fighting him without ample preparation."

Cocky little shit. Even in death, without a personality, he's telling me what to do. "Right. I'll keep your considerations in mind."

We walked down the hall, following my mental map towards the location of the door that should lead us to the world that Amelia was terrorizing.

I'm not looking forward to this. I don't want to fight the girl who saved my life.

But if it comes down to a fight... I refuse to lose.

Part 074: Emergency

"Beelzebub was defeated." President Ose said flatly. She adjusted her glasses as she looked at the paper in her hands. "Umi confirmed it."

Bael stared unemotionally at her. "So what? I never liked him anyways. He was a weakling who thought he could gain power with words and political favors. He was a worm." Bael flexed his grip lightly. "TRUE power is gained through actions, not words."

Agares nodded as he pet his crocodile. "Agreed. The Hero is becoming more dangerous and we need to finish him off, but defeating Beelzebub is no great feat. He's not even a duke."

Ose nodded slowly. "Yes, you are correct and your words are true. But..." She slid her paper down to Agares. "...have a look at the manner in which he won."

The table went silent and the other members watched Agares eyes as he read. They had only just convened this emergency meeting under President Ose's orders. They had not yet read the report.

Agares shifted uncomfortably in his seat. "Really? Umi confirmed it? A single word? It's ridiculous." He tossed the paper down on the table and sneered. "I'd have to see it to believe it."

Normally, Ose would pull out a video and show them but this time she shrugged. "I don't have visual confirmation, but Umi's word is good as gold. We've never doubted her now, and we aren't about to start."

Diablo, sitting at the head of the table, stroked his temples and nodded. "Yes. I agree. He is far too dangerous. This time... we really have to put a stop to him."

"He seems to have the ability to cast spells verbally, but his limit is a single word." Agares spoke again. After reading the report, he was still doubtful. "And his power appears to be essentially unlimited, as any effect he can think of will happen so long as he has enough magical power, and there is a word to describe what he wants."

Bael leaned into the table, suddenly more interested. "Really? Is he limited to just a single word? Not two or more?"

Ose shook her head. "I don't believe he can do more than one, but it's hard to tell. It may be a bluff. Umi has a 95% confidence in her analysis, but as we all know... *humans*..." She spit the last word out. She didn't need to say anything else. The other demons at the table also had their lips curled in disgust.

"...Miserable little creatures..." Mephisto was muttering under his breath. His incorporeal spiritual form was always an interesting sight. He wore a blood red tunic and a blood red phoenix feather stuck between his right ear and his head. His signature ability was that he could sense any nearby spiritual energy around him.

"Yes, they are little... but every so often, a pest will spring up and challenge my patience." Diablo beckoned at Ose. "Do you have a recommendation for anyone to send after him? We need to put an end to him now, before we lose any other assets."

Ose shook her head. "Don't bother. You're not going to believe this, but the fool is actually chasing after the Lord of Flies and her companion. He should meet up with her in one of the human worlds soon."

Bael actually laughed out loud. "Bahaha! Well then, if he has a death wish, let's let him do it!"

Diablo nodded. "Yes. I agree. If she kills him, we're rid of a pest. And if he kills her... well..."

Ose smiled an evil smile. "There's a reason we never broke her out of that prison."

The demons at the table roared in laughter. Their laughter shook the halls as the night carried on.

Part 075: Portent

I shifted my weight as we walked. I don't carry much anymore, not in the way of provisions anyways. I can summon anything with a simple word. *Fire, tomato, water...* I can make all the food I want and I no longer have to eat that goddamned infernal chicken anymore.

Glancing down at my waist, I felt noticeable disappointment as I always do. Hoarhiim. I had left him behind in Phoebe's care back in Hero City, and I've grown to miss his voice. I'm still connected to him, so if he reawakens I will immediately be able to speak to him again, but for the journey I'm going on, his presence would be more of a hindrance.

I don't need his light in the darkness anymore, I have perfect spatial awareness. If anything, being able to move silently in the darkness and not draw attention to myself has been a great blessing. His light would not only obviously give my position away, it would give the enemy ample time to react as I approached them.

I guess I don't really need the element of surprise, given how powerful I've become, but I always am cautious when it comes to the denizens of this hell. I still don't know how I'd fare against a Duke class demon or higher, and I'd prefer I don't find out before I'm ready.

We walked down the hallway and drew near the door that my map indicated would lead us back to Todoro and Peter's world. "**Disperse.**" I said, commanding my 10 minions to vanish. They simply disappeared into an unknown void, waiting for me to re-summon them. I kept Beelzebub here, if only because I thought he might be slightly useful.

The three of us stepped out of the door and into their world. The beauty of it was mostly lost on me, as I could no longer see normally. I could feel grass under my feet... and I could perceive trees and houses, as well as crops nearby. But the 'beauty' of nature was wasted on me.

Expanding my sphere of vision, I searched outwards, sending my mind to lots of different nearby areas.

"It's so good to be home!" Peter exclaimed, falling into the grass.

"Hold on. We posted two guards at the entrance to the door. Where are they?" Todoro stepped forwards and looked around warily.

Peter instantly jumped to his feet. "Ah, sorry, I got carried away. Why would they leave?"

I ignored his query as my mind roved around the place. "There is no life anywhere within 5 miles. That's my maximum detection range."

Peter nodded. "All the people here must have packed up and fled. Why would anyone live near a gate that opens up to Hell itself?"

Todoro seemed unconvinced. "The soldiers wouldn't have fled though. They would stay here until their duty was finished. We were only gone two days or so. There's no reason to have fled."

As the two debated over why the people had left, I reached my hand up to silence them.

"You're misunderstanding me. I didn't say there was no human life anywhere. I said there was no *life* anywhere."

They paused to consider my words, and horror grew on their faces as they realized what I truly meant.

Peter, almost whispering, spoke. "All the life in this area... is gone?"

Part 076: Discovery

We searched. For days, we wandered the lands. Plants still existed. Trees were here, as were grass and flowers. But there were no animals, humans, bugs, anything else.

And without animals and bugs, these trees and flowers and grass plots were living in their last days. The food cycle would quickly come to an end. Everything that was left would die.

The thought filled my heart with anger. Amelia did this. The one I considered a friend, the one who saved me twice and pulled me back from the brink of death... she was a monster who devoured all life. And now, two humans were desperately hoping that I would kill her and put an end to her reign of terror.

Could I do it? Not even "could" as in did I have the ability, but did I have the heart? Did I have the will to kill a cute girl who seemed so playful and fun? One who had saved my life?

I don't know. I can't bear to think of it. If I must kill her, I will have to somehow disable my emotions.

We continued walking for five days and five nights. My stamina was essentially inexhaustible at this point, I haven't slept in nearly 8 months. I kept "watch" as we slept at night. Figuratively of course, since my eyes can't see.

After a week of travel, we finally arrived at the castle.

It was in ruins.

To be honest, the words "atomic bomb" came to mind. Nothing was left that was taller than a single story. It almost looked like a massive hand had pressed down and crushed the castle into a dusty pancake. I felt no emotion as I looked at the scene, but Todoru and Peter were tearlessly weeping as they scanned the devastation, looking for survivors.

Because of my abilities, I detected several bodies crushed deep inside the rubble... but I didn't have the heart to tell them.

I sat down on a rock and meditated as they hunted all around the place for anything, anyone...

And behind me, a voice spoke. "Hi!! Were you looking for me?"

Part 077: Rage

"Were you looking for me? I'm right here!!" Amelia, as always, was amazingly cheerful and happy. Her garment was stained with dried blood. Probably from her victims. I sensed many patterns of what was likely DNA or residual spiritual energy, so it was likely this was the blood of many victims.

Amelia, perhaps sensing my 'gaze' suddenly raised her hands up and covered her chest. "Eww! Stop *looking* at me like that!"

"No... I didn't mean... the blood..." I said hesitantly, as my unseeing eyes swerved back and forth. Shit, I'm getting sheepish around an inhuman monster, I'm still treating her like a little girl.

"Oh! Just that?" With a giggle, she waved her hands, and the blood vanished from her garment. I could almost swear I heard a faint scream as it disappeared. "Okay, now that we're over that, how have you been?"

I almost mistook her question for genuine concern. I was still alarmed that I hadn't detected her approaching from behind me. I can't see her aura anymore either. Only when I focus on her can I sense anything.

"Amelia. You're full of energy, as usual." I started off with a neutral statement. I don't know how I feel about her. I still haven't decided yet.

"Yep! I'm doing great! And ah, where's Hoarhiim?" She ran around me, incredibly fast, in circles looking all over my body for Hoarhiim. She ran so fast I could barely track her movement.

Finally, she came to a stop in front of me again. "He's not here." I said simply. "I left him in the care of a trusted friend."

"Aww! No fun! Blaarjiim, say hello! It's not good to be impolite!" She chided the black orb in her left hand. I can't perceive light and dark anymore, so I can't be entirely sure..... but Blaarjiim seems to be...

" Hello, 'Hero'. I see you've gained quite a lot of power over the last year. "

Blaarjiim's voice was incredibly powerful sounding compared to how I remembered him in the past. His voice boomed in my mind, like the sound of ten cannons firing next to your ear. It was nothing compared to Gabriel from when I had been given his power, but compared to the voices over the last year, it was unspeakably loud.

"Yes, I've gotten much stronger. I've learned many things. I even learned about your past, Blaarjiim. As well as Amelia's past."

Amelia's cheerful smile froze, as did her body. "My... past? Explain." The smile disappeared and she stared at me evenly.

"Not necessary. Amelia, I came to speak to you. I want to know why you're doing... *this*." I beckoned to the destruction around me. "Why are you killing and consuming humans? Why have you become such a dark monster?"

Peter and Todoro came running up. Behind them came Beelzebub, who I had ordered to follow them around and sound an alarm if they were attacked.

Amelia's face somewhat lit up as the three came running up, and she ignored my question. "Ooooh! Snacks! And also- ah, Beelzebub?" Her expression turned quizzical as she saw the lord of fire following behind them. "I... thought you detested humans? Why are you following them around like a dog?"

She was clearly baffled. Beelzebub came to a stop and stared ahead blankly. Amelia, feeling puzzled, zipped over to him in a flash (*frighteningly fast, I might add*) and started waving her hands in his face. "Heelloooo~! Beelzyyyy" She grew annoyed again. "Damnit! Stop ignoring me! You're even more depressing than usual!"

Blaarjiim spoke up again. " **My queen, I do not sense the presence of the one named Beelzebub. Whatever you are staring at, it is now a soulless creature.** "

Amelia's eyes popped open in recognition. "Ah! So that explains it!" Running over to me, she laughed loudly. "You defeated the Lord of Fire and took him as a pet! That's so adorable!" Her expression became menacing and a disturbingly wide, toothy grin took over, as she got close to my face. "You're playing with *fire*, you know? Taking over bodies, playing god. If you don't watch out, you'll become the real *monster* around here." Her body quivered, almost as if the thought delighted her.

Peter, his own body trembling, spoke. "I-I don't know what the relation is between you! I just want to know... why did you eat EVERYONE?! They were our friends and family!"

Amelia paused, her face turning from mine. "Oh? I think the snack has something to say." The evil grin was still creepily frozen on her face. "I think I've devoured everything left on this world... but I'm still not full yet."

She started to jerk towards Peter, but at the instant she moved, I reached out and slapped her across the face, my hand moving at close to the speed of sound. Her body went flying backwards, tumbling into the tall grass.

She rose up, tears in her eyes. "H-hero! Why did you do that?! It hurt... uwaaaaa!!!" She... she started crying. Are you kidding me? Who would fall for this?

But Peter... when she started crying... he snapped. "You... you monster! How dare you cry, after all the... the people you've killed!"

Todoro was also shaking, but with anger. "Yes... you killed everyone we've ever known. A monster like you... you don't deserve tears."

I could sense what was happening inside them. Their emotions ran rampant as their blood heated up a degree and their hearts pounded furiously. I spoke, to try and calm them down. But when it came to it, pointless and futile or not, what they did was up to them. I had no attachments. "Calm yourselves, you won't stand a chance if you attack her. It will be a slaughter."

Tears streamed down Todoro's face as he eyeballed the child that had killed his family, his mentors, his teachers, and his king. "I know... but if I don't put a scratch on her... for my countrymen... I WON'T BE ABLE TO LIVE WITH MYSELF!"

And then he and Peter charged. I watched as they ran to their deaths.

I just watched.

Part 078: Regret

I don't know why I didn't stop them. It would have been easy. A single movement would have saved their lives.

Perhaps I wanted, deep down in my heart, to see if it was true. Amelia wasn't a monster... they had to be lying. Yes, she had a demonic aura around her, and she had said some odd things, but would a monster save my life twice? There must have been a misunderstanding.

Her power and speed had greatly increased since the last time I saw her. She had definitely done something to increase her power. Ingesting souls was as likely a reason as any.

Either way, I just watched as Peter and Todoro rushed to their deaths.

"Oh? The snacks are desperate to hop into my little chompers!" I lurched back in horror as her mouth unhinged and her entire head expanded to the size of a large cat, and she chomped them down in the blink of an eye. Even Todoro, one who I had thought was fast, was eaten in an instant. And within seconds, her head was back to normal.

I watched two good men die, and I felt no emotions about their deaths. Only a feeling of betrayal. A feeling that was caused by Amelia's lies. Well, not lies. She never told me she was a good girl. I just wanted to believe it.

"Amelia..." I choked back tears as the memories of her monstrous appearance came flooding into my mind. "Why did you... save me... you saved my life... why? If this is what you are, then..."

Amelia stood there, licking blood off her face with a freakishly long tongue I had never expected to see. "Umm... let's see! Why did I do it again? Gosh! I can't remember!"

Blaarjiim spoke. **"As I recall, my lady, you told me in private that you thought he would make for a good fight someday. That was it, really."**

I stared at the girl in front of me. She was back to normal now. No weird tongue. No giant demonic head. This girl... she saved my life, only so that we could someday fight. She really is... monstrous.

"Very well." I said, hardening my expression. "If a fight is what you want, a fight is what you'll get. I released you from that prison... I will put you back inside it."

I aimed my hand at her, and started to speak, but she dodged out of the way and appeared behind me. "Too slow! Teehee!"

"No." I said flatly. "You are too slow."

With a single kick, I smashed my foot into her stomach and sent her flying behind me into the ruins of the castle. Quickly whipping around, I aimed my gaze at her.

"Die!"

Part 079: Unexpected

Amelia staggered to her feet. "Ah... that REALLY hurt!"

I quickly aimed my hand at her again.

"DIE!"

I bellowed this with all my power. Nothing happened.

She stared at me, and started slowly laughing. "Heh heh heh..." Her laughing increased in both volume and power as she started bellowing in a deep, demonic voice. "HAAAAAA HAH HAH HAH!"

She slowly calmed down and returned to 'normal', whatever that might be. "You truly are an absolute fool. How stupid do you think I am?"

I took a step back. It didn't work? Was it ineffective against her because she lacked a soul? Was there something involving her and Blaarjiim VS myself and Hoarhiim? Perhaps the command only worked on others who didn't possess the Lord Orbs?

I didn't know, but what I did know is that, for some reason, *'die' doesn't work on her*. That alone is a scary thought.

"How did that not hurt you?" I decided to try the simple approach.

"It's easy. I'm not an idiot, I'm a dark queen that even the other demons fear. I am a strategic genius. And when I found that your abilities were due to the power of wordsmithing, I simply put several hundred layers of protection against word spells that you might try and use. 'Die' was *such* a predictable word. It's laughable that you'd even try it."

I nodded slowly. It made sense. She got me there. I don't know what words she blocked, but simple words would probably be useless against her. I'd have to do this trial-and-error.

"By the way, let's see how strong you've really gotten, oh mighty *Hero*." She spit the last word out sarcastically. I was going to retort but then she charged at me. Such frightening speed. To be honest, my speed may match or exceed hers, but without a way to focus on her as she moved, my spatial vision was mostly ineffective.

An attack from the back! And the left side! And the right!

I struggled to defend against it, as she pulled out a dark sword and cut me with it several times. She must have been testing me because the wounds weren't very deep.

Amelia jumped back, eyeing the damage. She had literally stabbed inside the chinks of my beaten armor. "That's it, huh? Worse than I expected. The power is good and the speed is okay, but fighting and being unable to track my movements? You've much to learn."

As she spoke, a thought crept in my mind. Jerking my hand out, I started to cast a spell. She appeared some feet behind me, avoiding my feet so she didn't get kicked. She's learning.

My spatial vision focused on her vision.

"Tracking!"

Suddenly, there she was. A bright red dot in my vision. I smiled. She didn't plan for that word.

"Huh? Nice try idiot, you missed me by a mile." She laughed as she saw my hand raised.

Good. An evil grin crossed my face. She doesn't know that I don't actually need to use my hands to aim. She hasn't been secretly following my development.

"Are you sure about that?" I asked, as I kept my back turned to her. "Why not try your luck... just *one more time*?"

She frowned. "Okay, but I won't go easy on you this time!"

"Don't worry about me." I said, holding a laugh inside. She has no clue.

She fell for it. Charging forwards, she stabbed at the chink in my armor, and my palm was waiting for her. SMACK! I sent her flying, but before she could hit the ground, I appeared underneath her, punching her into the back, up into the air, and then I delivered three more kicks directly into her spine. She gasped in pain and I let her smash into the ground.

"Does it hurt?" I asked, a wide grin on my face. "You keep thinking that I'm the pupil and you're the master, but I've already surpassed you. And now I will repay the debt you owe to those you consumed."

She grimaced. "You're sneaky, aren't you? You don't have to use your hands for spells, eh? I won't let you do that again." Her eyes burned with fire, as she once again unhinged her mouth. But this time, a massive swarm of flies erupted out of her from within her gut.

All right, that is officially the most disgusting thing I've ever seen.

Part 080: Battle Bowl 2

Simple words won't work. Amelia may say she's intelligent, but she probably won't know words from my world.

Looking at the swarm of flies that were about to hit me, I yelled again.

" Exterminate! "

Instantly, the swarm died, and Amelia looked pissed. "Those were my pets, you asshole!"

They could not have truly harmed me, but maybe they could have distracted my spatial vision or slowed my movement and hearing down... it could have made my situation much worse.

Amelia appeared to be mulling my powers over. "You really do possess many abilities, and you can make anything you want appear out of thin air... but..." She pulled out her dark sword again. It looked familiar to me. "When it comes to battle, I am much more seasoned than you, or any other demon. I'm going to make sure I take my time killing you, until you understand what true despair is!"

Suddenly, I recognized it. That sword, it was the one from my dream! But not only that, it was actually Dellfingler!

Amelia lurched at me again, this time quickly moving her hands to cast a spell. The sword *merged into her arm*.

Slashing and stabbing at me, I blocked her attacks with my bare hands. Now that I could track her position everywhere, she didn't appear fast to me at all. I punched hard at the spot I estimated her to appear, and right in time to blast her away from me, smashing through five layers of trees. When I tracked her again, I was shocked to see that her neck was snapped and her body covered in bruises. I... killed her?

No. The damage healed, and I noted a curious movement of energy from Blaarjiim to her body, as her neck straightened.

She got up, and stepped forward again. Suddenly jamming her hand into a tree, she lifted it effortlessly, using it as a massive crushing weapon. She charged at me and swung down.

I jumped away and it missed by a mile. It slowed down her movements noticeably.

"Grr... STOP MOVING! I'm going to squash you like a beetle!" She was visibly irritated that I was dodging so easily. This was easy. Really easy. I had always thought she was powerful, but apparently I've gotten even more powerful than her.

I can't be cocky. I refuse to let my guard down. I still know next to nothing about her power. All the demon lords I've turned into puppets had zero information on her abilities.

I decided to experiment a bit. "**Clone.**", "**Clone.**", "**Clone.**"

I summoned up three clones. "Kill her." I ordered them. If she had any new tricks, I'd know immediately. Each clone was half as powerful as me, but three clones were roughly 110% as powerful as I was, given the only somewhat coordinated teamwork.

It was vicious. Amelia didn't expect something like this. Over the course of three minutes, the clones attacked her relentlessly. Since I could stand back and watch, but also receive data from them, I noticed her attacks would grow weak, her body would be battered, and then she would heal up again. Each time this happened, that strange energy transfer from Blaarjiim would happen.

So that was it. She didn't eat the souls, she must have given the souls to Blaarjiim to hold. It made sense. He was a being of purely condensed spiritual energy. More spiritual energy would only increase his power, he probably had a limit but it was likely vast.

"Beelzebub, what are your thoughts so far?" I turned and spoke to the puppet. The puppet stared ahead blankly.

"I have no opinions due to your destruction of my original personality." Again with the jokes. I swear, this guy would make for a great deadpan comedian. Maybe if I learned to harness his wit, I could make a fortune in the stand-up districts. Worth a thought anyway-

Suddenly there was a massive explosion as Amelia erupted a dark wave out of her body. My clones stumbled back, visibly hurt and staggering in pain, but enduring wordlessly.

"I've had just about enough of this!" Amelia was throwing a tantrum again. Great. "If you want to pick on a poor little innocent girl, why not pick on someone your own size?"

I shrugged. "Tell that to the thousands of people you killed."

"Millions." She corrected me with a cold glare and a single tart word.

"Right..." Every time she spoke, I became more and more confident. I had to put an end to her. She has no compassion for anyone other than herself.

Amelia stood up straight. "You want a real fight then? Let's do this."

She held up Blaarjiim and grasped onto him with both hands. "Blaarjiim, *do the thing.*"

"**My pleasure.**" A wicked demonic smile sprouted itself in my mind.

Part 081: Darkness

Amelia and Blaarjiim were suddenly encased in darkness, as a massive cloud appeared over the horizon, blocking out the light of the sun. The sun's light disappeared and suddenly the day quickly became dark and dreary as a rain cloud formed over us.

Amelia and Blaarjiim began speaking together in unison.

The power of darkness gives us our strength

The terror of death gives us our might

While separate we stay at arm's length

But when together, darkness our power unites!

A dark cloud surrounded Amelia, as she and Blaarjiim finished their magic chant. It completely shrouded her from view. Inside, the red dot that I sensed vanished, and slowly became a black one as it reappeared.

The cloud withered away, and in front of me stood... something unnerving. It was still Amelia, but she appeared much older. Blaarjiim was no longer in her hands, they were both free. I could not tell what she was wearing due to my lack of eyesight, but Beelzebub described it for me. A black leather suit that encased her entire body, and a dark cowl that hid her hair, except that which hung out from behind the bottom of it. Amelia appeared to have gained more than a foot in height, and was now two inches taller than me.

But her eyes... her eyes now were pitch black. I did not need Beelzebub to inform me of this. I sensed two 'hollow' spots in my vision sphere, at the exact spot where her eyes would be. Pure black eyes that devoured the light around them, and the energy as well.

Her energy level was staggering. It raced out of her body at an explosive rate.

" You must have angered my queen greatly for her to have assumed this form. " Blaarjiim's voice spoke from out of Amelia's mouth. It almost seemed like...

"Did... the two of you...?"

" Yes. " The demonic voice was not as loud as I would have heard it in my mind, but it was still impossibly deep and gravelly. It reminded me of someone putting the bass on max with a subwoofer.

"Where is Amelia, then?" I stared 'her' body up and down with my mind. The presence had changed color. Was she simply dormant? Was she erased?

" She's... inside me. I have taken over for now. But enough questions. She hates doing this, and I would not wish to anger my queen more than necessary. "

He disappeared. Pain. I felt monstrous pain in the side of my head as he appeared next to me, smashing me in my right ear. The power was incredible, a wave of force erupted from the spot he hit and blasted the falling rain away and my body was sent flying helplessly across the ground. Before he could attack again, I managed to jab my hand out and stab into the ground, stopping my movement as I swirled my body around to face the attacker.

"Fuck." I cursed aloud, as blood trickled from my ear. He wasn't playing around. I dashed towards him and punched at him, teleporting behind him as I swung at the back of his neck. He ducked down in an instant, sweeping his foot under mine and tripping me, before I could even hit the ground, he punched me in the head, smashing me into the ground with incredible force.

He kept his fist pressed against my head. **" What were you saying, insect? Something about giving up? Don't make me laugh. "** He grabbed me by my right leg, and hurled me a great distance. Probably a half a mile or so. He hurled me away from the castle. The world spun and I struggled to regain my mental balance.

Before I hit the ground, I aimed my hand at my body.

"Halt!"

With a single word, my momentum stopped, though I began falling straight down I was able to land feetfirst.

Limping around badly, I quickly healed myself. The pain hurt but I just had to deal with it. I was getting a good sense of his movements now. He was definitely faster and stronger than me, two very bad combinations. But there is always a way out when you can make words reality.

"Invisibility!" I yelled, making myself go invisible. "Reptile!"

Now he couldn't track me with his eyes, or any sort of heat vision.

" Heh heh, isn't that cute? You learned some tricks. I guess now that I can't see you, it's all over, eh? "

And suddenly he was at my right side.

" Wrong. "

Another punch sent me flying.

Part 082:

The battle dragged on. I was exhausting my power, and so was Blaarjiim. His colossal presence had grown noticeably smaller. At one point, I used a teleport ability to return to the door to the labyrinth.

I was shocked to see that Blaarjiim was already there.

" Fleeing the scene of battle? I had pegged you as many things, but a coward was not one of them. I guess we're all wrong about something eventually. " He turned around and glanced at the doorway.

He smiled. **" My queen needs no sustenance to live. Even if this entire planet dies, we will live forever. But you... you're just a lowly human. On the off chance that you may win... "**

He made a motion with his hands. A colossal explosion destroyed the portal back to the labyrinth and it disappeared from sight. I stared at the sight of it in wonder.

" Teleportation will not return you inside the labyrinth, not now that there's no direct link. The dimension has been sealed off. "

I nodded, swallowing hard. "So this is it then. A battle to the death."

Blaarjiim nodded. **" Don't be conceited. It's a slaughter, plain and simple. I have weakened somewhat, but you have weakened greatly. Even if- "** He paused mid-sentence, and his head turned to the side. **" I see. My queen has seen enough. She is displeased that I sealed the door and will now be taking over again. "**

I breathed a sigh of relief. Amelia may be intelligent, but this was certainly a boneheaded move. She just can't help her impulsiveness. But still.

I looked again at the spot where the door was. Not good. I could probably teleport back to the Labyrinth somehow under normal conditions, but not in my weakened state. There was still my trump card, but I didn't wish to use it. It was thoroughly untested and only for extreme emergencies.

Blaarjiim's immense energy dissipated, and the dark cloud formed again as Amelia reappeared. She lost her footing and fell to the ground for a second, but managed to pull herself back up. "Whew... that takes a toll on my body..." She stared at me. I was no longer in perfect condition. I had lesions and bruises and cuts I had not yet healed in order to conserve my

energy. I was in bad shape. She however, was in peak condition, and Blaarjiim had used all his own energy during the merge.

Things were not looking good.

Wordlessly, she walked up to me. "Listen, Hero... um... I just want you to know, this won't hurt a bit... I'll make it quick, because I like you, okay?"

I slapped her.

This time, my slap barely knocked her off her footing. I was visibly weakened. I felt weaker.

She shrugged as she rubbed her face. "That's it, huh? Well, like I said, I wanted to make this slow and painful, but I was willing to give you a chance. You blew it though!"

She giggled another innocent sounding giggle. "Slow and painful it is!"

With a motion of her hand, she cast another spell.

At first, for a few seconds, nothing happened. Then I felt it. My entire body greatly weakened. I shuddered down to my hands and knees. My spherical vision disappeared. I was suddenly completely blind again. I fell to the ground, rasping for breath, as incredible amounts of pain in my arms and legs took over.

"You... what did you... do to me..." I gasped for air as I coughed the words out.

"Me? Oh nothing much. I just dispelled all those annoying buffs of yours! You spent the last year cheating by casting spells on yourself, didn't you?"

My eyes shot open as I realized what she had done. Every enhancement I had cast on myself, gone. I was still a strong human, but compared to the demon in front of me, I was just a... a...

"...Snack!" She said helpfully. Yes, that's the word. I might as well be another snack. I feel so weak I can barely move.

It's time now. I should have done this sooner. I didn't want to have to do this, but it's time for my trump card.

I wheezed for breath as I slowly raised my hand and coughed a single, breathless word.

" *Catherine.*"

The blood drained from Amelia's face.

"What... what name did you just say?"

Part 083: Catherine

The young girl bowed in front of the altar, her hands clasped together as she prayed to the man above her resting on the cross. Her parents tried to pull her away, as the ceremony had come to a close some time ago, but she resisted. "Just a while longer, please, papa?"

Papa smiled gently. "All right. Just a while longer." He walked away with mum in hand, as they spoke to the pastor on the other side of the room.

"She's a remarkable young girl. Pious, smart, she keeps to her studies well... I see a bright future for her." Father Miles smiled as he spoke of the child. She was one of his best choir singers, and she always prayed diligently, every day.

A nearby nun chimed in. "I should hope that you enroll her in the university someday! She will surely make for an excellent nun or a cleric!"

Her parents nodded thoughtfully. They weren't wealthy enough to afford such a thing. Maybe, in time, they might be, but they had 4 other children to care for. Showing favoritism was out of the question.

"Perhaps. We shall see. Thank you, father." Mum motioned to her daughter. "Come along, Joan. It's time to leave."

* * *

Joan's 16th birthday. She couldn't feel happy. God had blessed her, but he had also given her trials. This was... the hardest trial of her life.

She held her sister's hand. "Catherine... I'm here for you."

Catherine rested on the bed, layered under 5 separate covers. The fever wouldn't burn itself out. Her body was covered in boils.

The black death.

Joan's mother walked in the room, and quickly pulled her hand away from her sister. "Do not touch her, Joan. I know you love your sister but... if you should catch it too..."

"A punishment from God." Joan said quietly. "This plague, it surely is an act of god. Or perhaps, the devil."

"Yes." Mom said, as she mopped Catherine's head with a cold wet rag. "From one of those two, that is where it comes from. Who can know? Who are we to question the Lord?"

"Not I." Joan quietly whispered under her breath.

* * *

Joan's sister died a week later. The ceremony was held in front of the church where father Miles used to preach. He had passed away a year ago. Everyone seemed to be dying these days.

Joan cried as they closed the coffin on her sister. Mom and dad wept fiercely, as they followed the graveyard staffers walking the coffin over to the nearby graveyard. They gently lowered the coffin into the ground and the new priest, Father Gabriel gave his speech.

Every so often, as he spoke, Father Gabriel would look into Joan's eyes, and a gentle smile crossed his lips. Joan could not bring herself to smile back, but the expression on his face stayed with her.

* * *

The next day, she entered the church, as she had done daily for over ten years, and bowed in front of the altar. The sight of Jesus on the cross warmed her heart and filled her with hope. "My Lord... if there is any feat I must perform, any favor I must do... I would do anything to bring Catherine peace."

From behind her, Father Gabriel appeared and lightly touched her shoulder. "Joan. It is good to see you. How are you holding up?" His voice was soft and kind. He was a wonderful man, one who would be able to lead the House of God after the passing of Father Miles.

"I'm doing as well as can be expected." Joan said, trying her best to smile, though it was cracked and weak.

"Joan..." Father Gabriel walked to her right side and sat on a nearby bench. "Come, have a seat. I have something I wish to discuss with you."

* * *

Joan gasped, as Father Gabriel walked behind the Altar of Christ. Inside a hidden compartment that he pulled forwards, there was a sword. A silver sword was there, one that seemed to be plain and otherwise bland.

Gabriel pulled the sword out of the drawer and walked over to Joan, the sword lying across the flat of his hands. "Joan, do you know what this is?"

She shook her head vigorously. "It is clearly a sword, but the significance of it, I do not know."

He nodded slowly. "This is a special sword. It came from *heaven*, many many years ago. And do you know what is truly special about this sword?"

Joan lightly shook her head. "Isn't... coming from heaven special enough?"

Father Gabriel smiled. "No, my child. The truly special thing about this sword is... it was buried here by a patron saint of this church."

He looked into Joan's eyes intently. "And that saint. Her name was Catherine, of Alexandria."

Joan stared at the sword in wonder. "Saint Catherine... why have I never heard of her?"

He shook his head. "Her existence is a secret. Only a few people in the entire world know. She was slain by a demon, and her will stated to hide the sword here for a future Hero of our people, one who could redeem her."

Joan nodded intently, taking the sword in her right hand. "The Sword from Heaven. It must be... a truly divine blade."

Gabriel nodded. "This sword was not just wielded by Catherine. It was wielded by many other heroes. It has existed for a thousand years, and now, you have been chosen to be its next wielder."

Joan stared intently at the sword. "Father. What must I do?"

Gabriel smiled, as he indicated a locked door at the back of the church. "Follow me. There is a very special place I must take you to."

Part 084: Sword

I staggered back in horror as my worst nightmares were coming true.

"Haha... you're kidding, right Hero? That's not really... her sword?" I laughed nervously as Hero stood, the Sword of Heaven in his hand. He was on the verge of death a second ago, but he had far more than a second wind now. His wounds were healing, and all around him, energy was being sucked in. The grass and flowers died around him and the air around him seemed to be thick with death.

Wait. That's not right. That can't be her sword.

Hero, despite now being full of power and wielding the weapon I hated most, had a sad expression on his face. "I'm sorry, Amelia. I didn't want to have to use this." His unseeing eyes stared ahead numbly and his hands gripped the sword fiercely. "Ever since Joan died, this sword hasn't been the same. It changed when it was left hidden inside the labyrinth."

I hadn't felt fear in so long. The sword was definitely different. It was *even more powerful* than when she had wielded it.

"What the hell happened... how did you get your hands on *Catherine*?! We thought and hoped it was gone forever!" My thoughts raced, after that battle... the sword had disappeared. Where could it have...

"The labyrinth giveth, and the labyrinth taketh away. After Joan sealed you, her body was too weak to go on, and she died a while later. I know about your past, Amelia. I know how you were stopped."

I could feel rage burning inside me... this little shit... he thinks he can stop me? He's not half as dangerous as Joan was. Joan had not an ounce of hate in her heart. Joan was truly a warrior of the light. Compared to this *child* playing god with puppets and souls and corrupting Catherine with dark energy, Joan was a goddess of the light, he was a pale shadow of her power.

I smiled evilly as these thoughts crossed my mind. "You're nothing compared to her. You can't defeat me. Hoarhiim has forsaken you, you left two friends to die, and you come at me alone. You have no real power!"

I laughed. "Ha ha ha! It's so cute, seeing you struggle like this! Now I understand, you didn't want to use the sword because it's too much for you to handle! Ha ha ha!"

Hero shook his head. "No. I found this sword in the labyrinth, as I did the other legendary artifacts. I didn't want to use them because I found that each one had been corrupted with dark

power. Only Solomon's Crown was untouched. But... if it takes a monster to kill a monster... I'll do what must be done."

Hero raised his hand again and spoke.

"*Achilles. Aegis. Orion. Hermes.* "

Corrupted pieces of armor appeared on Hero, one by one, as he summoned them. His chipped and cracked and weakened white armor was quickly replaced as dark energy replaced the white.

A tear flowed down his face. "The Armor of Achilles, the Shield of Zeus, the Belt of Orion, and the Boots of Hermes. All legendary treasures from on high, all of them ruined by this godforsaken hell. And if I must wear them to defeat you, I will."

Speaking again, he quickly cast spells.

" **Detect! Infrared! Sonar! Tracking! Targeting! Perception!** "

His head nodded as I could again feel his presence following me.

"Let's continue from where we left off. We will fight again, but this time, on equal terms. As monsters."

Part 085: Rabid

Heh heh heh... I can feel it slipping away again. My personality is changing even more rapidly... I've never worn all of the armor at the same time.

My unseeing eyes darted and spun around wildly, as I started breathing much faster than usual, almost panting, like a rabid dog. Amelia could sense the change. She grimaced. "Not good. If you want to fight like a monster, I'll bring Blaarjiim back out." She started to cup Blaarjiim in both her hands, but I staggered forward at a speed that terrified even myself.

"You think I'll just let you transform?! ONLY AN IDIOT WOULD DO THAT!!" My voice was wild, it was monstrous. I don't remember sounding like this. I don't think this is actually my voice.

She stumbled back and yelped when I charged, quickly bringing the mute Dellfingler out to deflect my advance. We traded a couple blows, but thanks to Hermes, I was FAR faster than either of us had ever been.

Why was I fighting her again? I think I had some silly reason before, but now I just REALLY wanted to tear this girl to pieces!

I pounced from behind her, playfully smashing her back and forth with the flat of my sword. "Hard to defend what you can't see COMING, isn't it, little witch?!" I sped around everywhere, the boots allowing me to move so quickly that my body was leaving afterimages. That Hermes, what a guy!

Amelia, beaten and battered, had no time to heal from Blaarjiim or summon him. In a desperate move she tracked onto me, and stabbed at my heart, full strength, with Dellfingler. It was easily deflected.

"What?! You think you can just stab through the invincible armor of Achilles?! And with a DARK weapon at that?! Get real!" I whipped Aegis around and rammed her with the flat of the shield, rushing forwards so fast the momentum kept her stuck to the front of it as I plowed through the forest. Smashing through at least a dozen trees, I came to a stop and she flew forwards, crashing into a mound of dirt.

She wheezed and coughed as tears poured down her cheeks. Delicious looking tears. I licked my lips in anticipation. "Hero... you... what have you... become..." She gasped the words out, as she dropped Dellfingler and ran her hand over her ribcage. She surely had some broken bones in there. *Mmmm... bones... those sound GOOD.*

I smiled as an inhuman laugh passed my lips. "A MONSTER, you moron! I'm a monster now! You made me do this, but I don't regret it one bit!"

I grinned maniacally at the wheezing and gasping girl, but seeing that she was barely able to even more, another emotion took over.

Boredom.

This was too easy. All this POWER and I can't even have a good fight?! This was lame! SUPER lame!

"Alright fine, fuck it, I'll let you and Blaarjiim merge. Make sure you don't die too quickly now though, you hear?!"

Amelia gave a light, pained smile. "Thank you Hero. I knew there was still some good left in you..."

Ah, that silly bitch. There's no good left in me. I've forgotten my real name already...

Part 086:

Amelia changed into Blaarjiim as I watched. When he appeared, he looked down at me with scorn and disdain.

" The mind is willing, but the flesh is weak. I see you've given in to temptation. "

I grinned at him as I felt drool dribble down my lips. "Oh please, cut the sanctimonious CRAP! It's so good to be BAD!" I leaped at him and he stepped back, knocking me to the side with one hand, but I was on him again in a flash from the other side. Yes... this was it... I'm so powerful now that Blaarjiim can't hold a candle to me. My speed and power are omnipotent. I could take on the three emperors of hell as it currently stands. After I'm done toying with this shrimp, I'll go and fight them tomorrow. With the speed I move, getting there will be no problem!

I darted around, cutting him in several places, cackling maniacally as I watched him struggle to heal the spots I cut and fight me off at the same time.

Everytime his hands went up to make a spell motion, I smacked them out of the way and kicked or punched his arms and shoulders. They were clearly slowing and he breathed heavily as we fought.

I came to a stop in front of him, watching this weak maggot trying to fight me back... I still wasn't having a lick of fun.

"Heh heh, is that it then?! All your boastful words, all your bragging, and you can't even stop me!! You'll soon die, you know?!" I laughed raggedly as my throat caught on something and I spit it out, coughing some more. I glanced at the ground. It was dried blood. Ah yes, that's right, the side effects of the armor... oh well, it's not like that matters now!

Blaarjiim healed himself to full again, staring at me evenly. **" I've fought so many beings over my lifetime. I am thousands and thousands of years old. I don't even remember the days of my youth anymore. You are not even a challenge to me. "**

He stared around us, at the dead grass, the lack of life, the fields covered in death, and up at the barely visible sun in the sky. My dark aura devoured everything, even to a degree his queen had not been able to.

He slowly shook his head as he looked back at me. **" You are still just a child. You have no real power, no formal training, no concept of honor or loyalty. You know**

nothing of the universe in which you were born. You play with dangerous tools of death, in order to seek petty revenge. But as for me... "

Blaarjiim smiled as he rested a hand on his stomach. **" I serve my queen. I do what she tells me to, for she is truly timeless and wise. You will never be able to compare to her. "**

I shook my body, for some reason and trembled as his words came over me. "Big words for a dog that barks for his master! You're just a useful tool for Amelia! You have lost all self autonomy and you do whatever she tells you, whenever she does!" I laughed. "I may be a monster, but I do as I please. I will go on to defeat the most powerful beings of this hell, after I have finished you off first."

Blaarjiim smiled deeply, an evil cackle escaping his lips. **" Haaa ha ha ha! You?! Defeat the most powerful beings in this hell?! How could you possibly do that, when my queen has already done so?! "**

I paused. Hm? What was he talking about? "Alright, I will... *bite*. What could you possibly mean by that statement?"

Blaarjiim beamed confidence at me. **" In your year of travels and hunting down lesser demons, you never once pieced it together? You never figured out why after Joan defeated my queen and put her in the statue to live in eternal suffering, and none of the other demons broke her free? They were SCARED of my queen, you imbecile! "**

Blaarjiim guffawed mightily as he shook the ground with his laughter.

I grimaced. He she done something incredible? Something truly monstrous? Surely, she was strong, but... "You're bluffing." I tried the simple approach.

Blaarjiim stopped laughing and his voice went icy cold. **" Ah... I don't think so, little one. "**

Blaarjiim paused and his hands made a quick motion. I thought of interrupting, but curiosity took over.

Darkness filled the land. Blaarjiim and I stood alone in a dark void, all other things disappeared. Far in the distance, I could see Beelzebub, staring wordlessly and vacantly at all that surrounded him.

And on the ground in front of Blaarjiim and I, a satanic pentagram covered in blood appeared.

" I think it's time you meet the former master of this labyrinth. "

A demon began rising out of the ground. His skin blood red. His head had two long, pointed horns. His body was massive, nearly twenty feet tall, and his muscles looked strong enough to crush a mountain. He gazed ahead vacantly, his body covered in flames that seemed to trickle out of his eyes and down to his feet.

" Hero, I'd like to introduce you to Satan. The previous First Emperor of Hell. "

Part 087: Satan

This is not good.

I probably could take Satan on easily. I definitely can defeat Blaarjiim. But now it's two on one, and I'm not so sure I can defeat the highest devil emperor and a fairly strong demon with potent magic all by myself.

I glanced back over at Beelzebub. Useless. He wouldn't even slow them down.

I remembered my three clones from earlier. It was better than nothing. " *Reintegrate* " The three clones dissipated and their power returned to my body.

All right, now that I have done that, time to try and kill two demons with one sword!

I grinned up at Satan. "You're a big guy, ain'tcha? Let's play around a little!"

Blaarjiim smiled. " **Amelia defeated him all by herself. She had no help from me. Let's see if you can do the same.** " He then stepped back and sat down cross legged in the black void.

Blaarjiim made a motion and... life returned to Satan's body. He turned to me and spoke, his voice surprisingly quiet and normal sounding compared to his intimidating presence and the power of Blaarjiim's voice. "Who are you? Why is there a little mouse in front of me?"

He eyed my armor and my weapon. "Ah, I see. You must be a Hero of some sort."

He turned around back to Blaarjiim. "You summoned me for this? Are you mocking me?"

Blaarjiim shook his head. " **I lack the ability to defeat this one as I presently am. He deals in tricks and deceit. I will not interfere with the fight.** "

Satan sighed. A great sigh of *boredom*. "Disappointing. I sense much power coming from this one, perhaps more than even Amelia in her prime... but all of that power is concentrated in the Mythological Artifacts."

I was giving him too much time. Satan was already sizing me up and assessing how much of a threat I was. This was the time to strike!!

I lunged forwards, swinging the Sword of Heaven at his calves and- hit air? He was gone.

"Over here, peon."

He was a hundred feet behind me. I grimaced. This demon was fast.

I charged again, but now my boots of Hermes felt like they were slowing me down. I could sense black veins appearing on my cheeks as I again swung at air. Satan was gone.

"Do you know why I was the most powerful ruler of the labyrinth for over a million years?" Satan's voice came from behind me. I cocked my head back around. He loved getting into my blind spots, but I have no blind spots. He simply moved that fast. "I always learn from my mistakes. If I do something wrong once, I never do it wrong again. I underestimated a weak little girl a single time, and it was the death of me."

A powerful blow struck me in the gut, but Satan hadn't moved. Another ten blows pummeled me from all directions. Still, he did not move.

"They called me invincible. The Ultimate Attack, and the Ultimate Defense. You can't hit what you can't see, and you can't defend what you can't perceive."

An especially powerful blow struck me in the spine as I staggered forwards. I suddenly felt something *shift* inside me. Blaarjjim's head jerked up slightly at he aimed his gaze at me. "**Hm? Your eyes...**"

My eyes, normally glowing white from the power of Hoarhiim, dulled back down to a cloudy, lifeless white. It didn't change my perception of anything, but everything seemed... *foggier* all of a sudden.

I spit blood on the ground as I fell to my knees. "D-damn... you're... you're definitely the First Emperor of Hell..."

Satan shook his head. "I no longer hold that title. The next emperor in line took it after I was defeated."

I stared at him intently with my all-seeing vision. "Then... if Amelia defeated you, why isn't she the First Emperor of Hell?" *Empress*, I corrected myself mentally.

" Why indeed? I think that perhaps she thought the job boring, a lifeless uninteresting task of day to day tedium. She left it to the second emperor, and went on her merry way... looking for a greater challenge. " Blaarjiim seemed to tire of the conversation. " Clearly, you will not be the one that defeats her. It's always been her greatest wish, to be bested by a great warrior. "

I grimaced. "Wasn't Joan a great warrior? Did it not fill Amelia's heart with happiness to be bested by her?"

Blaarjiim shook his head. "**Lady Joan was a far more cunning and powerful warrior than you, but she could not ever bring herself to kill. Not even a demon. She instead sealed my queen inside the statue and left her to rot, before Joan went on her merry way and died like a rat. "**

I understand now. Amelia doesn't just want to be defeated... her greatest wish is to... die? It's such a sad existence. Wait, sadness? How can I feel sadness? Are my emotions returning?

I felt the Armor of Achilles with my hands. It was badly cracked and chipped. Was Satan's power really that monstrous? I was easily defeating Amelia, even Blaarjiim after he merged with Amelia... how could she possibly have defeated the First Emperor of Hell?

So many questions. My mind was filled with rage and lunacy before, but I feel sanity returning. I must be nearing my final limit.

Satan stared down at me with his oppressive gaze. His gaze seemed even more bored than before. "To have bested Amelia yet to fall before me... her power has been greatly reduced. But this... I cannot allow this farce to continue."

He moved, and in an instant, he was kneeled down in front of me, as his fist uppercut me into the air. Again, a hundred blows struck me in the span of ten seconds, as darkness exploded from my body.

I came crashing down into the ground, and I felt broken. Utterly, completely broken. I was a child playing Hero again. I still think I'm invincible... but I'm not.

I spit, and twenty of my teeth fell onto the ground in front of me, blood pouring from my mouth. Pain seared through my brain as the agony hit me in waves.

Satan shook his head, watching as my legendary ultimate armor disintegrated into the wind. All I had now was Catherine, and she lay on the ground a few feet from me.

Satan walked over and picked up Catherine, the sword as small as a knife in his colossal hands. "So this is the sword that sealed the one who defeated me, eh? So much power, but what good is it if it breaks the wielder's sense of logic and reason? This is more of a detriment than a boon."

Using two fingers, he reached his other hand up, and *snapped* Catherine in two.

A great cry of agony rushed out of the sword and Satan stumbled back, dropping it as the scream had even startled him. It sounded like a million souls pouring over a great dammed-up river. "By the gods, what happened to this holy weapon to make it such a fearsome demonic harbinger of death?"

The sword smashed into the ground, falling with unusual dense force, as if gravity had suddenly increased one hundred times over around just it alone. It left a massive crater in the dark ground, and then it too dissipated into the wind.

All my incredible armor is gone. Everything but the Crown of Solomon. Hoarhiim has left me. I left friends to die. I brought no companions but demons with me. I am completely

crushed.

Blaarjiim smiled. " **That will be quite enough, Satan. You've done your job as expected.** "

Satan whipped his head back around and glared at Blaarjiim. "Hm? So that's it? You summon me out of weakness and now you're sending me on my way?"

Blaarjiim shrugged. " **I do only as my lady commands.** "

Satan grimaced as he turned back to my broken husk of a body. "Cheh. Very well then. Farewell, 'Hero'. Enjoy the rest of your miserable wretched life."

He turned back to Blaarjiim. "Return me to my slumber. I wish to have more enjoyable dreams. And... *don't* bring me out again unless it is absolutely necessary."

Blaarjiim glared back at Satan. " **If I should ever wish for your opinion, I will ask for it.** " With a smooth series of motions, Satan faded away, as did the black void around us.

With my armor gone, the sun shone in full force in the day sky. It hadn't seemed like much time had passed, but it was already the brightness of midday.

Blaarjiim walked towards me slowly. " **So this is it, then? Your body broken. Your bones shattered. Your spirit humbled. You now understand what true weakness is. Twice now, my lady has healed you back from near death, and this time proves that like all filthy humans, you never learn.** "

I would have nodded if I could feel anything. I could barely even twitch my finger. He's right. I am completely irredeemable. I can't call myself a Hero. At best, I'm still that same old Child of Gaia, running in fear through the labyrinth. I haven't changed one bit.

"Hoarhiim..." I whispered... "I'm sorry that I forsook your guidance... now I understand why you left me... and never returned. I am truly sorry, from the bottom of my heart."

Blaarjiim stood over me now. Dellfingler was in his right hand. " **You were not a challenging opponent but... you brought some joy into my queen's heart. Perhaps, if you were stronger, she might have even... fallen for you.** "

He raised the sword above me and held the point of it above my chest, and prepared to stab my heart.

"I will die alone then... I came here alone... I will die alone, as do all humans in the end." Tears rolled down my face as the end finally came to me.

" *No. You are not alone.* "

A voice sprouted itself from within my mind.

" I have always been with you. I have always spoken to you. You simply never listened to what I had to say. "

My tears faded as hope entered my heart. *Hoarhiim?*

Part 088: Hoarhiim

I walked over to the small, broken human on the ground. Pulling out my sword, I raised it over the feeble body of the youth.

" ...Perhaps, if you were stronger, she might have even... fallen for you. "

And then I stabbed the sword down.

It pierced his heart, instantly killing him. I pulled the sword out, my gaze darkening as I looked at the corpse in front of me.

Now that Hero was dead, my queen could return. But... in my haste... I had destroyed the door to leave this place. Perhaps the reason I did so, was that I knew I would win. If we cannot escape, then my queen would be alone, with only me by her side.

Just me... the thought filled me with joy. I would have the most powerful queen ever all to myself. Even if it took an eternity, I would find a way to create a real body for myself, once again... to undo what had previously been done.

I love my queen. I may be the Lord of Darkness, but it is merely a title. It's a transient thing. Titles mean little, they are passed around like candy at a party. I'm fortunate that my title reflects my current abilities, as I am truly a lord of darkness, but even if I were the Lord of Fire or the Lord of Flies, it would mean nothing to me.

I turned away from the unsightly, broken corpse behind me. I walked away from it slowly, pacing myself. My lady probably had no feelings for the youth but... I would not reawaken her and have her control the body right in front of his shell. If she did possess feelings for the insect, it would be unnerving for her to reawaken right in front of his body.

I walked away, and before I'd taken ten steps, a familiar voice spoke. One I had not heard speaking aloud in...

" Where do you think you're going? "

Hoarhiim.

I turned back around and gasped. The body had silently healed and he was standing up, perfectly straight. His wounds were all gone, but more impressive were the other physical changes. His muscles hulked. His entire facial structure was altered. He definitely resembled my old rival in body, and in voice.

" Hoarhiim. One last trick, huh? "

" This is no trick, Blaarjiim. This has been fated since the beginning of our lives, since we first met, as youths, all those years ago. "

I nodded. I could no longer remember my distant past, and he likely couldn't either. But he was right. We always fought, we always bickered, we always argued.

" You are the light, I am the dark. Neither of us can win, you know? "

" No. You are wrong. This one is unique. I will finally achieve my ultimate goal through him. "

I gnashed my teeth. **" You think it will be so simple? We've fought tens of thousands of times. It's always a stalemate. We are equal in power. The light needs the darkness, just as much as the darkness needs the light. "**

Hoarhiim shook his head, as a spear of light appeared in his hand. *Gungnir*. His personal weapon. *" Many things have changed, one of which is that I now have the ability to control fate itself. "*

A bluff if ever there were one. I summoned my own weapon, sticking Dellfingler back in its place at my side. **" Sharur. "** A mighty club of darkness appeared in my hand. Ah, so good to feel its power once again. The only time I would ever take this out was when I fought my rival. Not even my queen knew of its existence. It was an unspoken rule between him and I. Personal weapons only.

I stared up into the sun, as its light beamed down on the battlefield. The ground was torn up and loose from the fighting. Patches of grass were missing, here and there.

Master, are we to fight Hoarhiim once more? My club spoke to me. Sharur was a sentient weapon, one of the few in existence. It sometimes had a mind of its own, deflecting attacks that I might otherwise miss, and striking weak spots I might otherwise not see.

" Yes, my brother. We will finally, on this day, strike him down in combat. And then we will be alone with the mistress until the end of time. "

The club trembled with anticipation. *You focus on defense. I'll worry about the attacking.*

Good. This would all be over soon.

Part 089:

I stared mindlessly at the fighting going on in front of me. Through a cruel twist of fate, a mere human had imprisoned my soul and body in his grasp. I cannot move under my own willpower anymore. I cannot speak, move, or otherwise interact with anything.

I simply stare out of my eyes, unblinkingly. I can't even move them to follow what's going on. Everything I see is a blur.

Hoarhiim and Blaarjiim, the lords that condensed their power into spherical bodies many years ago, are now somehow in human form. I stand very far away from the battle, in relative safety I might add, as they have all but ignored me.

I don't like safety though. I wish they would simply kill me. A lack of autonomy is true hell, having to wordlessly endure the suffering of being ordered around by a lowly human... this is true Hell.

A great mind once said that suffering is different for all beings. For a slug, pouring salt on its body brings incredible suffering, yet many forms of livestock would greedily eat that same salt if given the chance.

There are those who hate any kind of pain, and those who love to feel it. People exist who love the sight of fire, and others exist who abhor it.

And for me, this is my hell.

A total lack of bodily control. Watching helplessly as far greater beings amuse themselves with a battle of the ages. They get to have *fun*. They get to stay alive and retain their autonomy.

Perhaps it is my fault. I always thought myself perfect, I always thought of other beings as lesser, yet in the end, I was bested by a lesser being. When I think about it, I realize that I was the lesser being all along. I'd weep right now if I could.

Sigh... I can't even close my eyes and sleep.

This... is true Hell.

Part 090: Battle Bowl 3

Our attacks were thunderous. Every impact made the sound of a small bomb going off. Our fists and weapons collided faster than the speed of sound. If I took a hit, Blaarjiim took a hit.

We really are still evenly matched.

I paused for a second to catch my breath, and Blaarjiim did at the same time. " *Tell me, old friend, why and when did we start fighting?* "

" **We aren't friends. We never were.** " Blaarjiim took long, slow breaths, at the same tempo I did.

" *Were we originally human, or were we demon? I can't even remember my original form.* " My gaze dropped to my spear, the *Gungnir*. How long have I possessed this weapon? Was I born with it? Did I forge it in the clouds of heaven, perhaps the pits of Hell? Did I find it amongst some old ruins? Millions of years I have lived, always fighting Blaarjiim. My life is a blur. My goal in life seems distant and hazy.

Why do I wish to rule the labyrinth? Why do any of the demons there wish to? Am... I even a demon? Am I an angel? Most demons are weak to the power of light, but it makes me stronger.

I gazed up at the sun. This would be it. My final stand. I am strong in light, and Blaarjiim is strong in the dark, but against each other, neither of us ever holds an advantage.

I turned back to gaze upon the black, hideous aura that rippled off him. He had ingested thousands, even millions of souls from this world. He had consumed all life that could produce any form of thought energy. Even so, his power was still not greater than mine. Even if he consumed all life in the universe, I would still equal his power.

It was a curse that had haunted us for the shorter part of eternity, but it would end today. All thanks to the powers of this human.

" *You still think humans are beneath you, don't you? You still, after all this time, underestimate their spirits. They have suffered much because of the Great War between angels and demons, but they still fight on. Across an infinite number of universes and an infinite number of worlds, they always fight on. They possess something neither you nor I possess.* "

Blaarjiim gazed at me with interest. " **Oh? And what might that be?** "

" *The survival instinct. Humans fear death more than anything else. They may willingly bludgeon one another to death, but in that same respect, they would do anything to make their*

short lives worth something. I have seen it time and again. With this hero, with Joan, and with many before her. They simply want to make the universe a wonderful place for their kind to live. "

Blaarjiim sneered. " **And they will do anything, including genocide of their own kind. Truly enlightened. "**

" No. Not enlightened, willful and proud. But above all else, they are an evolving species. Our kind is stale. They make new advances constantly, in their grasp for power. Someday, the average human will exceed this one's current abilities. "

" Exactly. This is why I must rule the labyrinth, so I can crush them before that happens. "

" No. I cannot allow you to achieve your goals. "

He charged at me suddenly, using his club to smash Gungnir from my hand. I quickly assumed a defensive stance and tried to repel him, but he grabbed me by the throat and slammed me to the ground.

" Even this probably won't kill you! You are an infuriating opponent! Why can't you just DIE so I can complete my quest?! "

I choked as his grip tightened. Wrapping my hands around the one he choked me with, I struggled mightily to pull him off me, but could not do so.

" Ha... ha ha... I said I would win, and I will not lie, I had hoped to finally defeat you here once and... for all, but... " I choked the words out as he held his grip on my throat. *" ...you will not let me win the fair way... therefore I must use this child's power... just one more time. "*

My eyes raised up to the sun again, as I gazed at its incredible glory. This will be the last time I see its light. Farewell, world of the humans.

I jerked my hand up and aimed it at the sun.

" SUPERNOVA! "

Part 091: Finale

My opponent took his hand off mine, and aimed it up in the sky.

" *SUPERNOVA!* "

* * *

Nothing happened.

" **Ha... haha! That's it then, eh?** "

I felt a tremendous amount of energy release from his body, the amount seemed to be nearly every ounce of power that he possessed, only a trickle stayed. His body and mind weakened noticeably.

I paused. " **Hmm. Did you do something?** "

I stepped off him and gazed up into the sky. Everything appeared to be normal. " **Was that some kind of ultimate trump card? It didn't do a thing, you old fool! Gwahahaha!** "

Hoarhiim weakly crawled to a sitting position on his knees. " *I have learned many interesting things as of late. This child knows of a great human philosopher who once said 'Knowledge is power'. And since I possess knowledge that you don't, I possess power that you don't.* "

I guffawed. A good bluff, as usual. Is this all Hoarhiim had become? A fantastic bluffer? I had expected so much more from him. When had my old rival turned to tricks and deceit? Was he not a warrior of the light?

" **Hoarhiim, this is why I will rule the labyrinth someday, and you will not. Your age is starting to finally show.** "

I chuckled softly to myself. However, Hoarhiim was not laughing. His face was completely blank, as he gazed up... at the sun. I turned around to look. Nothing had happened... why was he constantly looking upwards?

Hoarhiim sighed. " *Humans invented a concept many ticks ago. It is a concept called Science, one you and I are far too old to understand. Truth be told, I would not know of Science were it not for the mind of this youth whom I have paired with.* "

He continued. " *To be brief, there are two things you must understand. The first is called the speed of light. Light travels at 186,000 miles per second. Nothing currently exists that this child knows of that can break the speed of light.* " He turned his gaze from the sun towards me.

" *The next thing you must understand is what a supernova is. A supernova is caused when a star explodes. The sun, up there, in the sky, is a star.* "

I nodded. " **Alright, I see now. But you've made a mistake.** " I beckoned towards the in the sky. " **It hasn't even exploded, you IDIOT! Gwaaaahaha!** "

Hoarhiim smiled a gentle smile at me. " *You still don't understand. I don't know at what speed my magic travels, but it's likely the Sun has already exploded. The light of its explosion simply hasn't reached us yet.* "

I stopped laughing and paused to consider his words. " **Wait... could you mean... it will reach us soon?** "

Hoarhiim nodded. " *The child does not yet understand the power of the Crown of Solomon. He is still a young whelp. But... I do. I have already made the calculations. The light of its explosion will reach us in four minutes, twenty-two seconds.* "

He nodded at me slowly, knowingly. " *And the instant you and I see it, we will already be dead.* "

My heart stopped when he said this. Could it really be true? I have no idea if he's telling the truth but... in all the years I've known Hoarhiim... like a good little child of the light... he's never once lied to me.

" **Hoarhiim... you must be jesting... if it explodes, we will both die.** "

Hoarhiim stared at me, deep into my soul. " *No, Blaarjiim. Have you forgotten? My orb is not with this child. I am safely hidden, elsewhere in the labyrinth. As I said, since the start, I have already won.* "

My mouth gaped open and I fell to my knees. " **You... you tricked me. You planned this... from the start.** "

" *Nay, I did no such thing. I merely made the most of an impossible opportunity. It was you, Blaarjiim, who devoured all the life on this world. If even a single soul were left, I would not have had the will to destroy the Sun. It was you, Blaarjiim, who destroyed the return path to the labyrinth. Had you not done that, this would have been an ultimately futile move. I made the most of the opportunities you gave me, but you... you are the one who created these opportunities.* "

Hoarhiim got over, and walked up to me, placing his hand on my shoulder.

" *Blaarjiim, it is you who killed your queen.* "

For the first time, in my entire existence, I felt something deep inside me. Anguish. Sadness. Raw, previously untouched emotion.

" No... I can't... my queen, she... "

Hoarhiim took a step back. " *And as for this child, he will not die on this day either. You couldn't win even a single meaningful battle on this desolate unforgiving world. Farewell, brother.* "

And before I could make a move, he said a single word.

" Return "

The boy's body vanished.

Part 092: Chapter 1 End

As I returned to my body, I gazed around, looking for Hero. "Wow! Great job! You must have really destroyed him! I can't even see a trace of his body anywhere!"

Blaarjiim was unusually silent. Usually he'd be saying something like *It was but a trifle, my queen*, or *I need no praise from you, only to stay with you forever*. He's usually so romantic like that!

But... he's silent right now.

I looked around and spotted Beelzy standing all alone. How... odd.

"Oh Beeelzzzyyyy!!" I dashed over to him and waved in his face, but he was mute. Oh right, that guy, he's just a puppet now. Sigh.

There was no sign of Hero anywhere. I even used search magic, but of all the places I had traveled on the planet, he was in none of them.

" My... queen... "

Finally, Blaarjiim spoke up.

"Oh Blaarjiim, wow you must have done a heck of a job here! I can't find him anywhere!" I was giddy with excitement. Now me and Blaarjiim would be able to hang out and play in the grass and have all kinds of fun times! It kinda sucks we can't re-enter the labyrinth but it's fine, I love my minion to death!

" My lady... something happened, while I was in control... "

Blaarjiim sounded... sad? I've never heard him sound sad before. My smile disappeared as I looked at his orb with concern.

"Blaarjiim... are you okay? What happened while I was under?"

A long, uncomfortable pause. I didn't like this. I don't like it one bit.

" Hoarhiim appeared... during the final battle... and he won decisively. "

I frowned. "He won? But, we're still here. Wouldn't a decisive win mean that he killed us?"

" No my lady... he has escaped into the labyrinth along with the boy. We are trapped here. "

I stared at him silently. We're trapped? That's unfortunate. Maybe we can return to the labyrinth somehow. Magic is powerful. "Come now, don't be too hard on yourself. You guys have always stalemated when you fought. Even if he's back in the labyrinth and you destroyed

the door to get back..." I gritted my teeth. This imbecile. What was he thinking, doing that without my permission? There's no more snacks here!

"Well, even if that is the case, don't worry about it!" I smiled cheerfully. Blaarjiim seemed to have taken this really hard. "We'll escape here eventually! Nothing can stop me if I put my mind to it!"

I sat down on the ground and kicked my feet up, and stared up at the sun. It was a beautiful white color. Strange though, I could have sworn this was a yellow sun before.

" My queen... we won't be returning to the labyrinth. We are in our last minutes together, if we even have that much time left. Hoarhiim did something incredible before he left... and we're going to die. "

I stopped smiling and stared at Blaarjiim. He wasn't joking. Whatever happened, it must have been horrible. "Blaarjiim, what happened? Just tell me already."

He paused again, as a mental image of him wincing entered my mind. **" He used his power to create what he called a 'supernova'. It caused the sun to explode. We only had 4 minutes left before the blast hit us when he told me this... it has been three now. "**

I quickly looked back up at the sun. Oh my god... it's even whiter than it was a minute ago, and noticeably dimmer.

"You're... not joking... are you?" I gaped at the sun that was dimming more and more every second. It was also getting smaller at a frightening speed.

" My queen... Amelia. Before we die. I wanted to say something that has been on my mind for thousands of years. "

I looked back into the pitch black orb. Blaarjiim's eyes mentally gazed into mine.

"You don't have to say it..." I whispered as tears started to cloud my vision. I could feel my chest tightening and breathing sharpen. "I... love you too, Blaarjiim."

In the blink of an eye, everything went white.

Part 093: Epilogue

I awoke suddenly, face down on a cold marble floor. The room I am in is dark, with only a single light source illuminating everything. Of course, I can't see light due to my blindness, but this was a light source that was perceivable due to it being spiritual energy.

"Hoarhiim!" I yelled in surprise and barely staggered to my feet. My body was in absolutely awful shape. I stumbled and fell back to the ground with a painful thud. The hard marble gnashed my broken bones together.

"H-Hoarhiim! How am I where you are?! I left you in Hero City!"

Hoarhiim projected a mental image of himself nodding. "Indeed you did. I used your wordsmithing to return you to myself."

I nodded slowly. "Then... wait! Amelia! Blaarjiim! What happened? You took over and I lost all consciousness! Are they still trapped on that world?"

Hoarhiim didn't answer for several seconds. "...yes. But, not for long."

I grew alarmed. "They will escape then? Damn! I had meant to put her down once and for all. I released her from her prison, and it should have been my job to put her back in it!"

Hoarhiim projected his face into my mind again. "Quiet. Stop using the crown and stop thinking so much. Listen carefully. After you let me take over your body, I fought with Blaarjiim for several long, grueling hours. He and I are polar opposite ends of the same coin. If one of us is strong, so is the other one. I finally won by causing the sun over that planet to explode. I used a spell derived from a word in your language. *Supernova*."

I paused for a second. Supernova? Like, making the sun explode? That's insane, how could Hoarhiim have that much power?

"You're sure they didn't survive, right?"

Hoarhiim was silent. "In less than two minutes, we will know for sure."

I frowned at his comment. "I see. Mysterious as always. And what about Beelzebub? Is he here?"

I glanced around but didn't see him. Hoarhiim mentally rubbed his head. "Ah, yes, there was another, wasn't there? Just recall him and he should be fine."

I nodded. I didn't have a whole lot of magical energy left, but this would have to do.

"*Recall*."

Beelzebub appeared in front of me, staring forward unblinkingly, as he always had.

"Heya Beelz, how are ya doing?"

He continued staring forward and spoke in a robotic voice. "I don't have any perception of feeling, but I would describe my body as in perfect condition, despite being your little toy puppet."

Goddamn, this guy is still as vicious as ever. "Ah, right. Hey, could you go upstairs and fetch Phoebe for me? Tell her we're in the Chicken Room."

Beelzebub nodded and walked away, up the stairs and out the door. I hope he doesn't give the other humans a fright. Come to think of it, maybe this was a bad idea...

Hoarhiim interrupted my train of thoughts. "Listen, Hero. When Amelia dies, as a feat for defeating her, according to Umi's rules, you will be granted a new name. Use it at your own peril. She is always watching you."

I turned back to look at Hoarhiim's orb, mounted on the altar. "You're very talkative lately. You don't usually speak this much."

"Yes. I have to be, if my suspicions are correct. Anyway, that doesn't matter. Listen, Hero, when we first met, you told me something important. You said you were from Earth. You were joking at that time, correct?" Hoarhiim seemed to be in a rush to get something out, but I didn't know what.

"Yes, I'm from Earth. It's not a joke. Why do you keep asking that?"

Hoarhiim projected a mental image of a flustered face. "Because it's impossible. Earth is the Original source. It's been dead for millions of years. You can't have possibly come from there."

Any trace of confusion or positive emotion that I may have had, washed away. "W-what? Dead? Surely you mean- and what wait, Source? The source of what?"

Hoarhiim seemed frantic now. "There's no time to explain you fool, if I'm correct then my time will be almost up. Listen, Umi is your enemy. You must find Marie, she is the key to all of this. If you can find Marie, you will have your que-"

Suddenly Hoarhiim's voice stopped. His mental image in my mind froze, almost like a bad video game glitch. I frowned. "Hoarhiim? Hello?"

Suddenly his mental image in my mind... *fizzled*, it made a motion like a VCR tape set to track incorrectly. Lines appeared in the image, and his mouth opened and let a wordless scream escape from it.

I watched in horror as his face dissolved from my mind. "Hoarhiim? HOARHIIM?!"

Phoebe and Beelzebub came walking downstairs at that exact moment. "Master? Why are you shouting like th-"

" **HOARHIIM!!** " I bellowed at the top of my lungs, as the light from his orb slowly faded, and a silvery, lifeless surface formed over it.

Hoarhiim was dead.

Part 094: Epilogue 2

I swallowed hard, as I stared at Hoarhiim's orb. It was silver, and completely dull. The silver looked almost like an unimaginably thick cloud had gathered inside his container.

Phoebe gasped as she saw him. "Oh... oh my... I'm so sorry... I just left for a moment but I didn't... he's..." She had her hand covering her mouth with a shocked expression blanketing her face.

"No, Phoebe, it's not your... fault..." I coughed the last word out. My body still badly ached. "Ah... Beelzebub, heal me please."

Beelzebub robotically walked towards me and then rolled his eyes. "I'm only doing this because you ordered, as I'm just a puppet. But at least you asked nicely." He did some fancy hand motions and my body started violently mending itself again, just as when I had healed myself over a year ago. That bastard, he did it with as much healing power on purpose, just to watch me squirm, didn't he?

After I healed, I quickly rose up and jumped at Hoarhiim's orb, still steadily sitting on its pedestal. And when I grasped ahold of his orb, I was confused but also filled with hope, as his orb was *warm* to the touch. Not terribly warm, but certainly about 80 degrees or so.

I picked up his orb gently and handed it to Phoebe. "Take him up to my room, I'll be there shortly."

Phoebe nodded and smiled. "By the way, Slayer, it's good to have you back." She turned and walked away.

Huh? Did she call me Slayer? I thought my name was Hero? What the hell?

I then remembered something Hoarhiim had said. *According to Umi's rules, you will be granted a new name.*

Umi. I don't know who that is. But if Umi sets the 'rules', then whoever it is, they must be very high up and very powerful.

Come to think of it, what rules was Hoarhiim referring to? I don't know of any rules.

I turned to Beelzebub. Seeing him stand there, robotic-like, I felt a bit of pity for him. With Hoarhiim gone, Beelzebub was the last being alive who had witnessed my powers and abilities after I left Hero City a year ago. Or, well, the last one who was still *alive*. I corrected myself.

"Beelzebub, is there a way I can restore you to your original self but still keep you under my control?" As a puppet, he has to answer honestly. Would be nice if he had at least some

personality though, the current him was just depressing.

He turned and looked at me, for once without a robotic expression. "I ceased to be a demon of true sentience when you killed me, however I can become a loyal *dog* for you who has some semblance of a personality, if you still wish it."

I nodded. "I want your personality to come back."

"Fantastic." His voice was like dry bread scraped over a tongue. "I can't wait to serve you, oh great Slayer."

I paused. "There's that name again, Slayer. Why is everyone calling me Slayer now?"

Beelzebub rolled his eyes again. "Because obviously your actions led to the slaying of a demon so feared and reviled by her own kind that they refused to even break her out of an enchanted prison. I mean it's not the hardest thing in the universe to figure out, you know."

Beelzebub walked over and sat on the stone steps. "Finally, you gave me a degree of autonomy back. I'm so... *thankful* for your generosity." He let that word, 'thankful', roll off his tongue sarcastically. "I just don't know what I'd do without your guiding hand."

I walked over to him and hunched down, sitting cross legged on the floor in front of him. "Beelz, would you be so kind as to tell me what the 'rules' are for living in this place?"

Beelzebub had a small snarl cross his lips. "Don't you ever call me by- ah, I mean..." His snarl vanished as his face suddenly stiffed and then loosened again. Some effect of Puppet? Was he unable to speak back viciously to his master? Good to know. "...I mean, I'd be *happy* to tell you. Shocking that you don't know, you've roamed this labyrinth for nearly two years and were totally clueless on protocols that govern it. I'm shocked you're still alive."

I nodded, as Beelzebub began to explain.

Part 095: Truly Final Epilogue

Nobody at the table wanted to speak first. This was truly unprecedented. They all just stared wordlessly at the report placed in front of them, as they flipped through the pages.

A full report of the battle between Amelia/Blaarjiim and Slayer/Hoarhiim.

Finally, Diablo broke the silence. "This is... unprecedented."

Agares nodded. "This level of destruction... he wiped an entire solar system off the map." His crocodile made a rumbling noise and he reached down to pet it. "Quiet precious, shh."

Bael spoke loudly. "It's truly unbelievable! Not only did the Slayer win, he won conclusively, and destroyed the Lord of Darkness, the Lord of Flies, and even the previous First Emperor as well!"

President Ose pointed at something on the page as she twirled her blond hair and adjusted her glasses. "You're forgetting something though. It was not the Slayer who destroyed the star, it was Hoarhiim."

Bael glanced back at the paper and then nodded. "Ah, yes, I see the error. Interesting. So Hoarhiim finally managed to achieve a full merge with his vessel? Amelia and Blaarjiim had done that for ages. What took him so long?"

Mephisto spoke up, his pale ethereal form betraying no hint of emotion. "Beyond that, this 'Wordsmithing' as Umi calls it, it has too many unique applications. It would seem that Beelzebub and his minions were defeated by a single word. It has powers that can be activated practically in an instant."

President Ose nodded, as she reached into her bag and pulled out a new set of papers. "You're absolutely correct, Duke Mephisto. Which is why Umi has created a new guide that we must follow if we are to actually defeat the Slayer."

Bael sneered as he took the guide in his hands. "Really now? Are we that worried about him? A single puny human?"

"That 'single puny human' just put an end to the two terrors that killed and enslaved Satan some millennia ago. It's hard to overestimate his abilities at this point." Diablo chided Bael and he quieted down at the Third Emperor's words.

"Yes, but what is most interesting in the report is that Amelia was able to nullify the Hero's instant death techniques. She made it look effortless." Agares indicated a line on the initial

report, before setting it down and picking up the new guide. After skimming a few lines, he smiled devilishly. "Ah, it would seem I have spoken too soon. Umi never fails to amaze me."

Mephisto was also scanning the document. "How she manages to get this information is beyond me. She must be a truly brilliant oracle compared to all of the past ones we've used."

Ose smiled. "Indeed she is. Now if you will, turn to page one. We need to start setting up barriers for the instant death words, like 'kill' and 'die'."

The others at the table nodded in agreement, and the night grew long.

Part 096: The Beginning

I walked along with my child, a boy of youthful stature but with a strong aura about him. "He will lead the tribe one day.", that is what the village guru had told me. Aaron was my oldest boy of my 6 children, and I treasured him above the others.

A father should not pick sides. A father should love all his children equally. But Aaron was special. He was fearless. A great warrior, a great leader, he will be one of these someday, probably both.

Aaron and I paused at the stream, our spears in hand. "Aaron, today is your tenth birthday. You will have to become a man now, and start helping the other men in the village."

Aaron nodded as we stared at the stream.

I pointed at the water in front of us. "However, you cannot become a man until you are able to catch ten fish in a single day. Do I make myself clear?"

He stared at the water for a few seconds. "Yes father. I will do it on my first try."

Confident. That's why I loved my boy. Aaron was always so sure of his abilities. He always did things right the first time. He listened carefully, followed his instructions, and often improved the task during the process. These were qualities a village leader would need, especially when we may soon have to go to war with neighboring tribes for food and hunting ground expansion.

Aaron readied his spear as he hunched down and waded into the water. If I know Aaron, he'll easily complete this task. I'm not so sure about his brothers, but this will be a trifle for him.

Aaron stood quietly for several minutes, his body poised to attack. His eyes wordlessly followed the movement of the creatures below him. I took a seat on the bank and swigged some water from my canteen.

Aaron steadied himself as a rather large trout drew near. I smiled and leaned in, staring intently. In the blink of an eye, Aaron stabbed down and pierced the fish, impaling directly through the center of its body. A clean kill. Hoisting it up out of the water, he cheered wildly. "One down, nine to go!!"

I smiled at him, and broke out into a huge grin. "Well done, my son! You always make me so proud!"

Aaron beamed back at me, and as he turned to look away, he halted. And stared at something behind me with a look of... horror?

I tried to turn around but could not. I was... falling? I fell to the ground, as a silent agony overtook me. What?! Where am I?! Why is it getting... so... hard to... see... things...

* * *

I stared in horror as the demonic four legged beast cleanly chopped off my father's head. I gazed in terror as his smiling expression stayed frozen on his face as he silently fell to the ground. His head landed with a thud, and then... his eyes closed, forever.

I couldn't move. I couldn't speak. Absolute terror overtook my body. *Demons*. They were sighted now and again, but I've only ever heard father tell me stories about the imps. Small little creatures, easily kicked out of the way or stabbed to death. Troublemakers to be sure, and dangerous in large packs, but mostly harmless and annoying.

But... but... this... *thing* that had killed my father... I couldn't stop trembling. I've never been so afraid in my life. It stood upright, and it was only 5 feet tall, but imps are only a foot tall usually. This monstrosity was terrifying compared to the imps I'd heard of. It had two long arms, but each arm was simply a long piece of flesh with an unimaginably sharp sword on the end. This... *thing* existed purely to cut and kill.

It hissed at me as it curled up its lips into a smile. "*Small human. You will tell your people that we will no longer be trampled and spat on. We are the Scyther, the first evolution of the Demon race. Be on your guard, for we will cut you all to pieces. Our time for revenge is nigh.*"

The creature gasped and wheezed, a noise I could only assume was the sound of a gross vile sounding laugh.

"*Sorry about your daddy, little boy. I'll leave him for you to bury. Heh heh heh... humans are so weak.*"

And with that, the demon turned around and slowly walked back into the forest.

I stared at the body of my father, now slumped over, with huge gouts of blood spouting out of his neck. It finally tumbled over, coming to a rest on the ground.

Father... I can't... I couldn't even protect you... you have no right to be proud of me...

Suddenly, anger filled my mind.

The demons. I will make them *pay*.

Part 097: Hatred

Aaron surveyed the remnants of the battlefield. Bodies of humans, demons, and angels lie everywhere. Bits and pieces of arms, legs, weapons, you name it, they were strewn all over the place.

He stopped at a particularly disgusting corpse that had been mutilated worse than many of the others. It had large gashes torn all throughout it, and chunks of the chest and intestine were missing. This one was likely attacked and partially eaten. His stomach quivered. Not out of nausea, but out of rage.

"These villagers were good people. We didn't make it in time. The whole place perished."

Gabriel walked over and placed a hand on Aaron's shoulder. "Commander Aaron, don't take it so harshly. It's not your fault. Nobody could have predicted a new evolution this soon."

Aaron bit his lip as he fought back emotions. He stared over at the corpse of one of the new demon hybrids. " *Wraiths*. These monsters are so fast. We had preparations for the other four but..." Aaron trailed off as tears came boiling up. "I failed these people, just like I failed my father."

Gabriel took his hand off Aaron's shoulder. "We lost many angels too, you know. Casualties always happen on the field of battle. You shouldn't take it personally, the demons are crafty and tricky. They will always be the enemy of humans and Angels. They always deal in tricks and surprises."

Aaron stared numbly at the carnage in front of him. 25,000. That was the number of dead humans and angels. And the demons had only lost 3,000. "They adapt quickly. They evolve quickly. We can't even react until after they slaughter thousands of us. What hope do we have against these fast breeding monstrosities?"

Gabriel paused and contemplated the young man's words. "Perhaps... you should try to evolve faster than them? You humans have your weapons. With some ingenuity, perhaps you can create new ones to combat the demonic plague."

Aaron sighed. What good is a spear against a demon? Even a shortbow can't take them out at range. Only our copper swords deal damage, but we have to be right in their path. We lose every time.

"Gabriel... thank you. Without the help of the angels, humanity would surely go extinct." Aaron bowed his head lightly as he looked away from the destruction around him.

"No, child. It is a relationship of mutual benefits. Give worship to the one who created you. Be thankful for his blessings. And above all else, never fail to appreciate the gift of life that you were given in this world." Gabriel smiled as he turned around, sprouted wings, and flew up into the sky.

Aaron stared in wonder. To have wings... what a true joy it must be to soar among the clouds like that. He waved goodbye as Gabriel flew away, until he could no longer see him in the distance.

Part 098: Oracle

The demons gathered around, chittering and chattering excitedly as their almighty leader strode forwards confidently through the hall and up to his throne at the top of the war council room.

His face projected no emotion. But his body language projected fearlessness and power.

"W-we are so unworthy of your presence, great lord Satan, nyahahaha!" a little imp babbled excitedly as he zipped along the side of Satan's feet.

Two Wraiths stood, one at each side of his throne, mighty spears in hand. Their large and unwieldy looking forms belied their speed and agility. They were impossibly speedy assassins, sent to kill the high rankers in a human and angel army before the rest of the demonic forces swarmed and took out the rest.

However, these two were special wraiths, the second and third ever to evolve.

"Diablo, Lucifer, a pleasure to see you two as usual."

Satan walked up the bloody red carpeted steps and took a seat at the great throne. He sat down in a single smooth motion, no movement wasted. Satan was not like the other demons, he was the first one to evolve. He had been the first to kill a human. He had been the one to teach his brethren the art of evolution. But he had already evolved twenty times. His brethren, even the fastest of them, such as Diablo and Lucifer, had only evolved seven times.

Satan was a prodigy among demons, the only one who could be called a worthy leader. And now, he had reached a surprising new tier in his evolution. *Oracle*.

An unprecedented tier compared to the ones before him. It opened up his mind to psionic energy, allowing him to see things that could not normally be seen, and predict things normally thought unpredictable, such as the future. He had been using this as of late in a multitude of ways, notably to crush human armies and pick out the dangerous targets.

But... his power had many other practical applications.

He turned and handed a tablet over to Belial, one of his trusted subordinates. "Here is a list of my recommendations for the qualified candidates. See to it the Matriarch and the Breeders get this."

Belial nodded, her voice hissing as a small amount of smoke came out of her mouth. "Yessss, master Satan. I am but a tool for your hands to work." Belial did not evolve like the other imps did, she had a unique evolution, one that skipped the multi-legged branch and rose instead up a

more human-looking branch. She walked on two legs, and instead of talons, she had five fingers remarkably similar to a humans' hands. Satan suspected she would be of incredible use in the future, if he could just figure out how to make her look identical to a human.

Satan indicated the vast War Board on the Great Table in front of the throne. It sat about fifty feet away, but Satan had perfect vision as an Oracle and he had no difficulty seeing every bit of it. "Lord Bael, how goes the conquest of the human tribes to the east?"

Bael snorted. "The humans are uniting with the angels, but they lack leadership, and the angels see humans more like disposable pawns. The humans, likewise, see the angels as divine guardians, but they fear them and thus cannot bear to give orders to the angels, lest they offend them."

Bael laughed quietly. "They mesh together poorly. Compared to your superior leadership, they have no chance."

Satan nodded. "It's been ten short years, but look at all the progress we've made. We breed like ants, the humans like goats. We've killed off 5% of their population across the Earth already, and within a century, they will be eliminated."

The imps nearby giggled wildly. "Eliminated! Killed! Death! Destroy! Rip and tear apart! Nyahahaha!"

Satan beamed a big smile, something he rarely did these days. A leader must be feared, so only rarely would he ever project emotions for his minions to see. "Yes, finally. We are going to win this war quickly. We are going to crush the humans. And then we will crush the Angels."

His grin grew terrifying as a dark aura clouded around him. "And once we have killed off the humans and the angels... our revenge will be complete."

Part 099: Heaven

Gabriel arrived finally, landing at the secret entrance hidden in the mountain of Sinai. After having passed through the holy gate that hid the entrance, and several halls including a short pause at the Halls of Solitude, he found the dimensional rift that sent him to the Other Realm.

A truly marvelous place. The original reason for its creation was lost to eternity, but all gods and angels knew it had been created by the original, the highest God, who bore no known name. Famed throughout time as the Unknowable and the Untouchable, he disappeared, and was never seen or heard from again.

Gabriel entered the clouds of Heaven and entered through the gate that barred his way. He passed many familiar faces along the way, stopping to chat and say hello. He was a well liked angel, one of the Original Seven. Everyone knew his name.

He entered the halls of Olympus, the meeting place of the various gods. Only certain gods were barred from entering here, but their names were sacrilegious and never to be spoken aloud in this holy place.

Gabriel walked up to the throne of Kronos, leader of the Western world. Kronos was the son of Titans, the original beings created by the One who had made the universes. He was a colossal figure, towering over all beings. Titans were massive, like walking mountains. It is said that when they were defeated, their bodies formed the soil of the lands and gave birth to life as we know it.

Whether any of that is true or not remains to be seen.

Gabriel bowed in front of the throne. "King Kronos, it is my honor to speak to you."

Kronos looked down and saw Gabriel at his feet. "Ah, Gabriel. Good of you to return alive. How went the battle?"

Gabriel stiffened as he bowed, and then quickly smoothed himself and rose up to face the King of gods. "My lord, we are losing badly. The humans are being slaughtered, and even our forces have difficulty dealing with the demon hordes."

Kronos paused, staring long and hard at Gabriel. "Hmm. It is as you say. And the thought energy? Are we collecting it? Are the humans giving it freely?"

Gabriel nodded. "There is still much resistance, but many of the humans are now even openly worshipping us. Every time they pray, they give us much thought energy to combat the demons with."

Kronos smirked. "Good. As long as they do that, we will win this awful war. It's not like the humans have need of it anyway." He leaned back and sat straight on his throne. "Gabriel, soon we will have enough thought energy to create the first Cosmos Class angel. I want you to know that due to your diligent work, I have selected you to receive this honor."

Gabriel, not one to usually show heavy emotions, gasped at this revelation. "M-my King! Such an honor...? You think me worthy of it?"

Kronos nodded sagely. "Indeed. You have killed more demons now than any other angel, even five of our mightiest angels combined would not equal your might. You are clearly the mightiest."

Gabriel slowly shook his head. "But, of Michael and Raphael, I am only the third-"

Kronos raised a hand to silence him and then glared down at Gabriel. "You're not about to reject an offer by your King, are you? Raphael and Michael are their own beings. You are skilled at battle, they have far many other contributions to make. You will receive this honor graciously."

Gabriel nodded, dumbfounded at the news. He bowed his head humbly. "Yes, my liege. I will do as you command. Until then, I will keep fighting for the sake of the humans."

" *Angels.*" Kronos clarified, a tinge of venom in his voice. "You fight for the angels. Understood?"

Gabriel nodded again quickly. "Of course, my liege. Of course. Just... a small slip of the tongue."

"Good. I don't like mistakes. You've done very well for yourself so far, and soon you will be on a level high enough to collect your own thought energy from the humans. Try not to sympathize with them too much. They are just vermin to be used, after all."

Gabriel nodded. "I understand. I shall take my leave."

Kronos smiled, his expression softening visibly. "Good, begone then. And Gabriel... take care of yourself. If you die before the energy is collected, someone else will have to become the first."

Gabriel nodded. "Don't worry, my king. I will not be killed by the monstrosities below us. I would never allow that to happen."

Part 100: A Beautiful Day

A cool breeze swept across the plains, as the sun shone down upon the soft, rolling meadow. Trees with flowers were blossoming, fruits were ripe, and birds chirped sweetly to one another.

This is *hell*.

The two armies faced off on opposite sides of the field. Humanity was led by the Slayer, a man of incredible powers who had united all the nearby populations together to battle the menace to their future.

Across from them lay a great army of demons of various shapes and sizes, along with other uncommon and rare specimens, such as werewolves and whitewalkers, along with orcs and goblins. They were led by Mephisto, the Duke of Mist. He was a creature of intangible characteristics, his body being mostly transparent and ghostly.

Mephisto smirked at the army in front of him. "Nothing you do will ever matter. You have no way to defeat us. If you should surrender now, I will promise you a swift, painless death."

"And join you as undead soldiers in your army of evil? Never!!" The man screamed a mighty battle cry, and his army charged forwards. Mephisto did the same, leading his minions into the fray as they licked their lips eagerly.

* * *

I screamed in rage, as one of my soldiers, Darius, was cut down by an orc right in front of me. "You BASTARD!", raising my personally forged mighty battle axe up, I swung it down with incredible power, cleaving the orc cleanly in two. The other demons and monsters nearby took a step back in fright as they witnessed my inhuman power. *Good*.

Raising my axe again, I screamed unintelligible words of rage as I charged through their lines, slicing anything down that got in my way, shoving my men out of my way with brute strength as my gargantuan body plowed through foes towards my ultimate goal: Mephisto.

He stood with two orc guardians at his side, both of them massive monsters equal to my size. When they saw me charging, they squealed in fright and jumped out of the way. Mephisto smiled as I charged. "Come at me, 'Great' Leader. I'll test what you're made of."

He never even saw my attack coming. I swung my axe down suddenly and it passed right through his body as if it didn't exist. I grinned. "Now I've cut you down to size."

Then I gasped. He was perfectly fine. I had literally passed right through him. He appeared to have an incorporeal form.

He grinned even wider as he saw my confusion. "A good effort, but you'll have to do better than that."

Rushing the few feet that separated us, he closed the distance in a millisecond, shoving his palm forwards, and solidifying it the instant it hit me. In fact, he even made it pass through my arms I had put up to protect my face, impacting me square in the jaw.

I went flying, careening backwards, my massive body smashing down friend and foe. Anyone in the path of my flight was knocked over or crushed to death instantly.

I gasped as pain overtook my face. I don't need to see anything so my eyes are a moot point, but my jaw hurt like hell. This transparent ghost demon is no slouch.

" *Heal!* " I spit the word out, the agony in my jaw almost making it impossible to speak. That was a close one.

I quickly healed my face. I didn't notice the slightest drop in my spiritual energy. At least there's that. But this guy...

I aimed my hand at him. " *Die!* "

Nothing happened, of course. It wasn't working on any of the demons anymore, not even the lesser ones. I always tried it though, just to be sure. You never know when a proud demon might ignore the countermeasures and offer me a freebie on a silver platter.

Mephisto cackled with delight. "That's it?! Try again!"

I grimaced as I formulated a plan. If he wants to play this game, let's do it. I'll play ball. I aimed my hand at him again. " *Corporeal!* "

Suddenly his body came clearly into view. He seemed confused for a second, then he realized what had happened. As I suspected, he didn't protect against that complicated word from my native language. "Smart move human, but what if I do this?"

With a quick movement of his hands, he became immaterial again, then he did another movement after that one, and nothing seemed to happen. I yelled again.

" *Corporeal!* " And I quickly charged before he could cast his spell again, but- ah! He had protected himself from my word! He was still transparent, trying to come to a quick halt as I realized my mistake, I stumbled for a single second as he flew at me, passed through my body, appeared on the other side, and punched me in the back, sending me smashing face first onto the ground. He used a lot more force this time compared to the last.

I wheezed as the wind was knocked out of me. I tried to heal myself but I couldn't get the word out.

"Having trouble speaking, you scant little rodent? It's hard to use your spells if you can't speak, isn't it?" He cackled with delight once more.

These demons... over the last 5 years, they've gotten so much more powerful, or perhaps they are simply becoming more used to my manner of fighting. Now they're even targeting my mouth, throat, and jaw. But, I always have a trump card waiting, just in case that happens.

I gasped as I jumped to my feet. I quickly cast another spell. This was one I hadn't used before, at least not in front of the enemy.

" *Slow!* " Time crawled to a halt around me, as that familiar feeling of deja vu overtook me. This is just like what happened the first time Hoarhiim and I... no... best not to think about that.

Time was slowed, and my mental speed was still incredibly fast, but my body was slowed significantly as well. Time to fix that.

" **SSSSPPPPEEEEEDDDDD!** "

My mouth slowly formed the words as I put a ton of energy into it, directing the spell at myself.

Suddenly, my body moved normally. I quickly glanced all around me. Mephisto's eyes very slowly and poorly tracked onto my position. I've got lots of time now. I raced over to one of my men who was a second away from being brained by a particularly big orc with a spiked club. I decapitated the orc in one smooth motion and kicked the club out of the way as it fell, making it smash on the ground beside the man. He probably had no idea what happened, the lucky bastard.

I quickly and efficiently decapitated several other monsters in the area, as I felt my energy noticeably starting to decrease. The 'slow' spell is a cost over time ability, and moving around while time is slowed causes my energy to drop rapidly. I'll have to wrap this up quickly.

I quickly ran up behind Mephisto, who was slowly turning to try and follow my movement from earlier. " *Flesh!* "

The spell failed. Damn. " *Material! Physical!* " Neither of those worked either. This son of a- wait! One more word, he probably doesn't know this one!

" *Tangibility!* "

He slowly became flesh and blood in front of me, as he tried to track onto the position he heard my words coming from. I grinned evilly. *You're finished.*

In the blink of an eye, I decapitated him, chopping up other parts of his body into bits, and finally smashed the rest of the pieces down with the flat of my massive axe, literally crushing him into pulp before he could respond.

My energy is running low.

I quickly jumped up to a vantage point on a nearby rock, smashing a skeleton archer out of the way with a single blow. Poor boney bastard, he's lucky he can't feel pain.

Aiming my mind simultaneously at every one of my troops on the battle field I screamed at the top of my lungs.

"RECALL!!!"

Instantly, all my men vanished and returned to the designated point I had set before the battle. The enemies still slowly swung down at opponents that were no longer there. I grinned as my breath came in ragged gasps. Time is of the essence now. I'm down to critical levels of energy. I spared a quick glance back at the clone I had created before the battle. Good, he's in position. He'd goddamn well better be. They seem to be getting more and more independent these days.

I raised both hands and aimed them in the sky, as I formed a mental image of the biggest most solid and dense object I possibly could.

"METEORRRRR!"

From the heavens, the meteor that I had seen in one of my dreams appeared, but far bigger than even I imagined. As the last bit of energy drained from my body, I gasped two words when I saw the size of the object I had summoned.

"Oh... fuck..."

Darkness took me.

Part 101:

I awoke in a cold sweat. My clone stood over me, silently. Thankfully, my ploy had worked.

General Alexander and I had planned the attack on Mephisto for weeks. We didn't know much about him, but I've gained a lot of power over these few years. I've lost a lot of friends too. Too many...

Ever since Hoarhiim ceased to exist, I've been searching for answers. I need to solve the puzzles. Nothing I try will bring him back to life, no words or spells, nothing. He seems to be completely dead, but his orb stays warm, no matter what. I refuse to believe he is completely gone.

Many think me mad, but I believe that if I can achieve enough power and energy, I may be able to bring him back. He was my first real friend, he protected me, even at the cost of his own life, and I will not let him be forgotten so easily.

I stared at the flowers in the jar next to my bed. Phoebe must have put them there. She's always so thoughtful like that. She's been with me by my side for twelve years now. Ten years since Amelia was defeated. The demon kings, dukes, and lords no longer approach me, since they know I am dangerous. Those who do are swiftly defeated.

Today was unique though, as Mephisto was the first duke I've faced. He was definitely troublesome, with that intangibility... but thanks to my careful preparation and use of the Crown of Solomon, I had given myself enough leeway to deal with any irregularities during the battle.

I'm... maturing. I wasn't originally able to fully realize the power of Solomon's Crown, but I'm much more skilled at battle tactics than before. To be honest though, I'm giving myself too much credit. It was Captain Adams, the man I had left as co-ruler of the city, who had made the suggestion. "We have forty million men women and children. Why not make use of them and take the fight to the demons?"

The idea seemed silly. What use were regular humans against powerful demons, even against lesser monsters? But then Captain Adams explained his plan to me in great detail. It was a simple plan, really.

First, I start making clones. My clones don't vanish over time. Even if it takes a decent chunk of energy out of me, each clone will last forever or until they're killed, and they're far stronger than the average human.

Next, I set the clones to start training regiments of human soldiers, buffing the soldier's abilities gradually over time, hunting down the ones who seem most skilled and promoting them up the ladder.

By creating a formalized military force, and using the powers of my wordsmithing, we quickly began advancing the human army forwards, and soon we were a formidable force. Individually we were definitely weaker than the demons, but we possessed large numbers, and my clones were effectively their own fighting, mage, and healer force.

For his talent, I came to realize that I was not a worthy brandisher of the Crown of Solomon. So, contrary to every emotion in my body, I gifted it to him.

The results were astounding. I... am not a military genius. I'm a pretty smart guy, but I shouldn't be leading armies into battle. At least, not tactically. Adams, with the Crown of Solomon on, recreated my entire notion of a tactical genius. If I didn't know any better, I'd call him the reincarnation of Solomon himself.

Humanity's Army of Labyrinth Liberation. HALL. Adams named our new army to inspire zealotry for us, and fear for the enemy. HALL came to be a name whispered and feared among the low ranking demons, and openly debated among the high rankers. They just don't know how to deal with us.

It's been ten long years, but finally, we're ready to take the fight to them.

General Alexander, a high ranking officer in the army of HALL was by my bedside. "Good morning Slayer. It is a great joy to see you awake, though your clone would not have let you die so easily."

I nodded as I yawned. "We won, correct?"

His mouth jerked lightly as he replied. "Yes, but the results weren't... entirely positive. Demon planet Beta Omnicron 4 is... gone."

I stared into his eyes. "...Gone? What do you mean?"

He stared back, his eyes boring into my soul. "What I mean is... that meteor wiped out all life on the planet. You badly overdid it."

I swallowed. "My god... I... curses..." I muttered under my breath as I bowed my head towards my legs. I wanted a big meteor to strike down and destroy the army in a single shot, but that was...

Alexander cleared his throat. "Don't worry about it. We lost the planet, but there are plenty of others. One loss won't kill us. You safely recalled all our troops to the capital, as instructed, so the damage was minor."

I chuckled wryly. "Yes... and clearly my clone recalled himself and I in the nick of time." I glanced up at the clone. He stared ahead, blankly. Looks are deceiving. They don't speak unless receiving orders or casting spells, except for unique circumstances, but the clones are surprisingly free-willed. They also make for merciless drill sergeants and grill the troops like nobody's business.

I looked back to Alexander. "How is the door garrison doing? Anything to note?"

He shook his head. The twenty clones there are well taken care of, no intruders have been sighted in Hero City for months. Oh, and before you ask, the portal room is secured too."

I nodded again. The portal room. Another of Adams' brilliant ideas. I was the only known being who could create them. If I used the Crown's mental mapping ability, I could summon a portal to any spot anywhere in all universes and dimensions. I simply had to either know exactly where it was, or have another clone in that location. Adams had a special room built and a clone left on standby who could summon portals that led to any clone or any mental mapping spot in the labyrinth. The latter was only possible if said clone wore the crown.

To that end, since only one person could wear the Crown at any given time, Adams and I had created a co-ownership rule and set it on the crown. Myself, any of my clones, or Adams could wear it at any given time. It's worked out well for us. Humanity is at a peak never before witnessed.

Alexander spoke again. "Ah, that reminds me. Adams wishes to speak to you regarding something. Would you be so kind as to go see him when you're feeling better?"

I nodded. "I'm feeling fantastic right now. I really know how to heal myself, isn't that right, me?" I aimed my question in the general direction of my clone. He didn't respond. Man, that me is a real jerk.

"Good to hear. Make it soon, then. You know how his plans require as much time as possible."

"Right, right." I said simply, as I rose off the bed. I wonder what he wants to talk about?

Part 102:

I stepped out of my cottage and breathed in deeply. The sun shone down brightly on Hero City. Funny, it's still named after my previous name, but it's too embedded into people's minds to change it. Oh well.

My cottage was a small thing compared to the castle, but it suited my tastes. The castle is just too big and gaudy for me, and besides, who needs all that space? Better to leave it to Adams. He's just overall a smarter ruler than I am.

I walked off my front porch, past the row of flowers that Phoebe had planted. She lived in her own cottage on the other side of the road, but she took care of both of our houses. A truly kind and generous woman. I still don't know what these flowers are called though, they look totally different from anything I saw on Earth, and the name is hard to pronounce in its native language.

Walking down the lane, I gazed up at the buildings in Hero City. This city was positively massive now. It used to be a population of 40 million, but in just ten years we've added another 20 million or so. Not just from births and such, but from friendly monsters that have joined our forces (they exist!) and humans we've rescued from other worlds.

Honestly, I'm beginning to worry. This world is *small*. Like, the Moon that I remembered from Earth dwarfs it. I don't even know how grass, trees, weather, and all that other stuff developed on this world. Truly baffling laws of physics.

Right now, Adams is desperately searching for a bigger inhabitable world. The crown gives him the Mental Map ability when he wears it, and he's scouted out many doorways in the maze. Every monster we run into is a death trap waiting to happen though, and he is a truly kind king who cares for all of his subjects. He wants none of them to die in those labyrinths. There is no such thing as a death statistic to him, and he attends the funeral of all explorers who die in that wretched hell. He's truly the greatest man I've ever known.

As I walked down the street towards the castle, I spotted a commotion. Normally I'd send a clone to take care of it, but I decided to investigate it myself.

"Thieves!" I heard a man yelling in the distance.

Two men were robbing a female shopkeeper and had just fled the scene of the crime. They were surprisingly fast, though nowhere near as fast as me.

I quickly darted in front of them, lightly slapping them and sending them smashing onto the ground. They were completely dazed and I called for the nearby guards to apprehend them. I walked away from the criminals and some citizens shouted my name in thanks. Always nice to be appreciated!

But still... humans stealing from other humans? We should be fighting the demons, not each other. We should be stealing what is theirs, not what is ours.

I continued towards the castle. As I walked up the steps two guards saluted at me. I saluted back and gave a nod as I walked past.

After a few minutes of walking, I arrived in the War Room. Adams was sitting there chatting with two of his top generals, but he waved them off as I entered.

"Slayer. Good to see you!" He smiled cheerfully and requested a nearby maid to bring me some tea as I sat down. "I'm glad to see you are okay. I had worried when I heard what, um, *happened*."

I nodded sheepishly. "Yes, I must have gotten carried away. I still don't know my own power."

He shrugged. "These things happen. At least it wasn't a planet filled with humans, it was a demon planet. All that matters is that you learn from your mistakes."

I nodded. We continued conversing for a few minutes about the battle and how I defeated the Duke of Mist.

"Interesting, he was an ethereal being then? Just another ability to watch out for. Have you fought ghosts or any other beings like him before?"

I shook my head. "No. I have yet to see any in the labyrinth. He caught me completely off guard."

Adams took a swig from his cup and gently set it back down. "That could have been bad. I wonder why he didn't solidify his hand inside your body and rip your heart out or something?"

I cringed at that mental image. "Ah... yeah. Strange. Maybe he's simply never fought an opponent like me, and thought he could toy with me?"

Adams nodded slowly, deep in thought. "...Maybe... you defeated him so easily... I just... I find it hard to believe he was a Duke. He didn't sound that powerful to me."

I stared at the table in front of me. "Yeah... I don't know. Maybe..."

We both sat quietly for a minute, deep in thought.

Adams perked up again after a short while. "Oh yes! The reason I called you here! I have a request of you."

I nodded. "All right, what do you need?"

Adams suddenly looked confused, as if he was searching for a word. "It's, ah... it's hard to explain. See, you've been increasing the physical, spiritual, and mental strength of our soldiers with your clones and their wordsmithing but..." He paused, itching his head. "It's just that, we need some kind of new weapon or something. Something that makes our troops not have to get so close to the enemy. And not a bow and arrow either. Something more potent, you know? Ah... I can't even explain it. It's like the knowledge is there but I just can't tap into it."

I stared at him, the wheels in my head turning. Certainly, such things existed. But the problem is, I don't understand how to make such devices. *Guns*. What we need is guns. We need to blam blam boom boom the enemy to death. If we get in close, we're mincemeat. Even heavily buffed humans are no match for orcs and skeleton warriors with the body strength and endurance of ten men.

But I don't know how to make guns. I can't understand the theory behind their creation, even with the Crown on my head.

"The word you want, it's called a gun." I spoke up. Maybe if I explained what I knew, it would help Adams. "Guns are a weapon that existed on my world that I came here from. They are a metal weapon that fire small or large projectiles at enemies. Their range is far superior to a bow and arrow, as is their stopping power. The problem is, I don't know how to make them."

Adams paused, and then he clasped his hands together on the table and leaned forwards. "Can you explain anything to me? Anything at all? Just give me the basics. I'll *make it work*."

I shrugged and pulled a piece of paper from the stack on the edge of the table and a pencil as well. "Let me see that crown. I'm not a good artist, but I'll try and illustrate what I do know."

Adams quickly handed the Crown over to me. "Slayer... if this works... you have no clue how much it will help myself and the future of humanity."

I paused and stared up at him. "You're wrong. I do know. That's why I'm desperately hoping you can make this work, Adams. I trust in you, fully."

Part 103: Plans

Diablo smashed his fist on the table with incredible force. The table shook but did not break, due to the Demonstone's nigh-unbreakable properties. "WHAT?! He completely destroyed the entire planet?! Are you out of your MINDS?!"

Everyone at the table shrunk back a little bit, some winced visibly. Even Bael, usually the loudest and most boisterous at the table, was not keen to be heard.

"You listen here. This is NOT acceptable. We've been taking losses for TEN years now! TEN YEARS! I want RESULTS!" Diablo smashed his foot onto the ground in rage, and the entire room shook from the impact. Luckily the entire room was crafted out of Demonstone, explicitly for this reason. Diablo was prone to fits of rage.

Mephisto was the first to recover. "My liege, I accept full responsibility. I allowed him to corner me and as a result my world was destroyed. I will accept any punishment."

Diablo snorted angrily, his nostrils flaring as his blood boiled with rage. He glanced up and took note of the missing phoenix flower, usually tucked under Mephisto's ear. "You... wasted... HER GIFT!" He whipped his hand out and backhanded a glass of wine that had shifted precariously close to the edge, and the glass exploded in a fantastic display, smashing against the wall at super-sonic speeds.

He snorted again, this time visibly slower, as his rage seemed to subside somewhat. It seemed to most present that he'd gotten the truly angry bits out of his system. "That feather... it was the last artifact that she left us... you weren't supposed to USE it! You were supposed to hold onto it in case someone else needed it. You're supposed to be unkillable for devil's sake!"

Mephisto cringed and shrunk down in his seat a little.

Ose interrupted. "It's too late to worry about that now, Emperor Diablo. We have more important matters to attend to." She pulled out more papers from her bag and most of the table's members sighed. "Umi has reports for us to look over."

Bael threw his hands up in the air. "Fantastic! I love reading reports! Highlight of my day!"

Diablo glared a fiery look in Bael's direction. "Shut up, you idiot. I recall you promising to send someone after the so-called Hero 12 years ago. Whatever happened to that? Another failure?"

Bael shrugged sheepishly. "Oh, ah, that. I uh... forgot." He lowered his head and grimaced, waiting for Diablo's rage.

It never came. Diablo sighed deeply instead and slumped back in his chair. "Sometimes... I wish Satan was still here... he was so much better at this than I."

Nobody at the table dared agree. To agree would be to insult Diablo right to his face, a death wish to be sure.

President Ose stared at Diablo blankly, finally accepting that he'd finished ranting. "Splendid. Now that we're all calmed down and the issues were discussed, let's examine this report."

Ice filled the room, as the demons did so. "It's just... insanity." Agares stared at the report as he scanned the lines. "Their numbers keep growing. They've liberated three worlds now and taken over two of ours. The only good news we have is that all of the worlds so far are plainly inferior to their current homeworld. They're living in a very small space with limited resources... but... how long can that last?"

Diablo gazed around at the table, and the demons seated there.

Ose, the president of finance. She attended these meetings like it was her life's goal. Her battle power was weak, but her mind was sharp. She was also the only demon in contact with the oracle, Umi.

Agares, the Duke of Reptiles. He attended the great majority of these meetings, and was definitely one of the smarter demons here. He could always be trusted to bring up something useful for discussion.

Mephisto, the Duke of Mist. He attended these meetings because he was actually a crucial figure here. His ability to become completely invisible helped greatly with spying, though the ability also had a lot of downsides.

Bael, the King of the 7 princes of Hell. A monster who always attended the meetings because he always sought to be ordered out to battle. The most vicious and battle hardened of the people here, Diablo himself excluded.

Beleth, an upper ranked King class demon. She almost never attended the meetings. She was always off busy somewhere else, doing stupid things that Diablo failed to understand.

Counting himself, that put only 6 demons that should be at this table. With Beleth gone, there were only 5.

Diablo frowned. There should always be 7 here. He'd need to start enforcing the code on Beleth so she had to attend. But also...

"We need a 7th member. One to replace Beelzebub."

Nobody at the table had been expecting that. Some started to speak in protest, but paused and thought about it. Agares was the first to speak.

"Now that you mention it, we've been missing a 7th for a long time now. Should we simply ask the Second Emperor to join us here?"

Diablo cringed. If Belial was here, Diablo would no longer be able to sit at the head of the table, he would no longer be the leader. "No... we should not, ah, waste her time. Think of someone else, and then submit the recommendation for Ose to review. We'll dwell on this later."

Diablo rose from his chair, as did the others.

"Meeting adjourned."

Part 104: Inventor

Captain Adams is... a genius. He's far beyond me now.

I explained to him the basic principles of guns. Being a military commander, he immediately came to understand the principles behind gunpowder. And he took it in directions I hadn't even expected.

He stayed secluded in his room for 5 days straight, only allowing his butler to enter and exit. Even I couldn't get to him. I'm sure if it were an emergency I could have, but since this is the first time he's shrugged me off, I knew it was important.

Finally, he emerged after the 5 days were up, ragged and exhausted. His eyes sagged as he sleepily handed me a large stack of papers, all of them filled to the brim with drawings, sketches, and detailed plans. I started to look at them, but he waved me off. "Take these down to Mr. Stevens, tell him to get to work. It's time he earned his pay." And with that, he stumbled back into his room to sleep.

I arrived downstairs in the basement of the castle, in the Forge. It was connected to the Armory, where all the weapons made by the forge were left until they had an owner. Using the principles created by Henry Ford in my world, we had created factory assembly lines to smooth out and speed up the creation of swords and metal armor, but that was all to soon change.

I handed the designs to Stevens and as he read through the pages over the course of half an hour, occasionally pausing to grab coffee from the table, he gasped over and over as new applications for the technology I had barely even outlined seemed to spark his imagination.

Stevens finally finished flipping through the papers as a serene look of satisfaction passed over his eyes. "We can win now."

He turned to me. "Great Slayer... if possible, I want you to recall all nonessential clones in Hero City to the Forge. I have work for them to do."

I nodded. "That will be fine, but what do you want them to do?"

He indicated a few things in the papers. "Gunpowder... we have no way of making it. This world is too small, there are no suitable materials to be mined anywhere. They need to make large stockpiles of it through your ability."

I nodded. "I can arrange for that. I suppose you'll want metals like steel too?"

Stevens shook his head. "That won't be necessary. Planet Alpha Omnicron 2 has mines for the materials we'll need. We've recently constructed a hidden mining base there that the

demons likely don't know about. It leads directly into the portal room, so it's very secure."

I nodded. "These planet names, they're very complicated. It's going to be a bit tedious trying to remember all of them. Can't we start assigning names to various ones?"

Stevens shrugged. "You'll have to take that up with Captain Adams."

I shrugged. "Yeah, I guess so. But before I go, here's a few more clones."

I stepped back and spawned 6 new clones, draining my remaining magic power to low levels. Clones take much of my energy to summon, but their ability to do their own limited versions of wordsmithing are actually incredible. I can turn a single clone into a micro-factory, creating objects as I need them, and Adams has been constantly thinking up new uses for them. Truly remarkable.

I breathed heavily as I walked towards the exit. "There you go, Stevens. Don't waste their energy all right? Like me, they get tired if you make them summon too much stuff at once. I'll be off now."

Stevens nodded with a glint in his eye. "Slayer, thank you. More than words can say. This is the beginning... this is only the beginning."

I nodded. "I know."

Part 105: Doom

I sighed, and leaned forward a little bit, stretching my feet. The Master was working us hard these days, ever since the filthy humans started roaming these catacombs. I scratched myself with my claws, sadly noting that I still hadn't evolved to my second form yet.

Am I doomed to stay a weak little imp, only good for guard duty and screaming if the humans appear? The thought made my skin crawl.

Tvoorik groaned, as he leaned against the opposite wall from me. "This sucks. How long do we have to stand watch? I want to go and feed already, maybe watch some action down in the Pits."

I nodded as I coughed slightly. "This is the worst! I hate being on guard duty! Can't they even give us a chair! It's not like we're fast enough to flee if the filthy humans show up anyway! We're dead meat!"

"Calm down, Ylvusk, it's not that bad. I have an escape plan if we hear them coming." Tvoorik grinned as he leaned forwards, checking to see if the skeleton commander was watching. He wasn't. He just stared aimlessly at the wall, unmoving, as he always did. "Take a look... hehe."

Tvoorik turned around and quietly pulled on the labyrinth wall. A small hole opened up. Just barely big enough for tiny imps like us to fit inside.

I nodded and stared in wonder. "Is that... one of the hidden lizardmen tunnels?"

He nodded, grinning devilishly, while quickly pushing it shut so nobody else could see. "Yeah. But keep it quiet, alright? It's only for emergencies... I don't want to have to use it unless we have to... there might still be 'gecks' hiding in there."

'Gecks' of course was short for gecko, a slang insult we used to make fun of the little critters. Naturally, once we reach our second form, we easily tower over them, but they're dangerous while we're just little imps.

I sighed again, as I leaned back against the wall. "Just two more ticks and we can get the heaven out of here."

Tvoorik moaned as he leaned against the wall again. "Say, you heard about Duke Mephisto's defeat a few months back, right?"

I rolled my eyes. "Some Duke he was. He was beaten by smelly humans and they even destroyed his entire planet."

Tvoorik paused, as he thoughtfully pondered that thought. "Don't you find that just a little odd? An entire planet? Come on, humans aren't that strong or smart. They're dangerous to imps like us, but humans are really weak fleshbags."

I nodded slowly. "Yeah... so? What are you getting at?"

Tvoorik leaned forwards meaningfully on his spear. "What I'm saying is, it's a little too *convenient*, don't you think?" He glanced back over at the skeleton commander, still staring blankly at the wall. Thank the devils they're dumb as rocks. He looked back over at me. "I mean think about it... now that we're all afraid of the big bad humans, Diablo has all the reason to order us on round the clock guard duty. Just a little too perfect, eh?"

I shrugged. "Maybe, I dunno. What are you getting at?"

"Tvoorik frowned. Come on, look at the big picture. It was an *inside job*." I instantly rolled my eyes. Oh for Devil's sake, not this again. "I mean do you really think humans can make meteors and asteroids appear out of nowhere?! Of course not, only someone powerful like Diablo could do that!"

I groaned long and hard. This idiot and his stupid conspiracy theories. "I bet you think Satan faked his own death just so he didn't have to be emperor anymore, right?"

Tvoorik nodded excitedly. "Yes, yes! It was all written down in this grimoire that Veerus was telling me about! You see, Satan was really unhappy with-"

Suddenly, I raised my hand to shut him up. I heard something. The sound of stomping, like something running fast. My demonic chest froze its movement as I realized what that sound was.

Humans.

"Ahh! SKELETON COMMANDER! Skeleton Commander! The humans are coming!"

My hands started shaking and I started freaking out as I realized that we had a paltry number of demons to deal with any large number of humans, and there seemed to be a *lot* storming down that hallway.

And then my eyes narrowed and I quickly looked at Tvoorik. "Ah! The door! Get it open!"

Tvoorik quickly jumped into action, yanking the lizardman door open as we climbed in and he shut it behind us.

"Heh, I told you this would be smart."

"S-shut up!" I hissed at him in the darkness. "They're coming!"

He carefully slid open a small viewing hatch so that we could peek through and see what happened. My firey heart was beating faster than it ever had before in my entire life.

Part 106: Boomstick

We raced down the hallway, as I followed the red dot in my vision that guided me towards the targets. They're close, very close, and there's only a few of them. Perfect, this will make for a great test of the new weapons.

I halted as we rounded the corner and spotted a skeleton commander and 15 skeletons, along with two orcs. These weren't even a challenge for our unit of 30, even without the weapon. I grinned. It's time to have fun.

"Lieutenant Cody, we're ready when you are." One of my men aimed his new toy at the enemies. I licked my lips. Time to enjoy the sight of some dead demons.

"Fire."

The boomstick fired, and a short spear made of metal blasted forwards, instantly impaling an orc, passing through it and ripping off the arm off a skeleton behind it. The other orc leaped back in fright as blood gushed out of his comrade as he fell to the ground, instantly dead.

I quickly loaded the next boomstick bolt, and fired again, this time impaling through 5 or 6 skeletons at once, as they were all grouped up in the hallway. You can't kill an undead creature, but blasting them to smithereens makes it hard for them to attack you if they are completely disassembled.

By now, the other enemies had recovered from the shock and started charging at us. No problem. We get to test out the next weapon.

"Gunther, you're up." I spoke to the biggest man in our group, a towering behemoth of 7 feet tall who barely missed the top of this hall by a few inches.

He gnashed his teeth as he faced down the charging enemies. "ME HATE DEMON MONSTERS!" He bellowed as he adjusted his new gauntlet and charged at them. He's not the brightest fellow in our group, but he's one tough son of a bitch.

Gunther ran forwards, pulling his fist back as he took aim at a skeleton that had raised a sword to swing down and chop at him with. As Gunther swung his metallic arm at the skeleton, he pressed a button attached to his other hand, and a blast of fire shot out the back of his gauntlet, propelling his fist forwards with terrifying speed and power, right smack in the center of the skeleton's skull. His attack was so strong it smashed through the skeleton, and the skull exploded into shrapnel that stabbed (mostly harmlessly) into the other skeletons behind it. A

few pieces lanced into the orc in the rear who hadn't died from our initial attack, and he yelped in pain as the bits pierced through his arms and chest.

"Rocket fist" was a fearsome weapon. I'd seen designs for the Mark II Rocket Fist and I could not wait to see that applied in battle as well.

Better yet, the fist was self-reloading, with a total of six shots that could be used in rapid succession. Gunther used all six in the span of ten seconds, as he smashed through the first skeleton, spun using the momentum of his arm, bashed through the skeleton commander with his next shot, then on the third shot he swung his entire metal-covered arm in a wide sweeping arc, which took out 5 more skeletons at once. He moved so fast with the fist that it was hard for any of the enemies to hit anything but air as he darted through them and past them.

Another couple boomstick shots, and all the targets were neutralized.

"Mission complete. Weapons Alpha and Bravo were a huge success. All targets eradicated." I spoke into the communication device that was strapped to my wrist. It used some foreign technology created by the Slayer, but I didn't care how it worked, only that it did at all.

"Fantastic work, Yellow Team. Head back to base for resupplying and rest. This mission was a rousing success. Blue Team will be in the area soon to take out a second group of hostiles." Captain Adams, as always, was on the case. A brilliant leader who somehow managed to lead ten battle forces at once. How he did it, I'll never know.

We crushed the remaining disembodied skulls of the skeletons around us, just in case, and walked off to return to Hero City. A job well done.

* * *

Tvoorik shivered in fear as the fleshbags left. I trembled too. When they were finally distant enough that I couldn't hear anything, I whispered, swallowing my fear.

"T-that battle went worse than I th-thought..."

Tvoorik didn't acknowledge my words. He gaped in awe at the bolt that had hammered into the wall behind the first dead orc. "This... this proves my theory... Diablo must be giving these humans new weapons to scare us... we have to report this to the one above him, immediately."

I slapped my face with my hand. "Do you want Belial to kill us?! That lady is nuts! We should just go tell Diablo and let him deal with it."

"No!" Tvoorik rasped at me quietly. "He's the leader of the whole bunch of them! He's giving the humans weapons to consolidate his power over the demons! Don't you see this is all just a ploy to become the first emperor?!"

I rubbed my temples carefully with my claws, as my eyes squeezed shut from the stupidity I was enduring. "Tvoorik... if Satan killed himself because he hated being first emperor, wouldn't you agree it's a crappy position to be in?"

He nodded thoughtfully.

"Then wouldn't you also agree that if the job is that crappy, Diablo couldn't possibly want it?"

Tvoorik paused as my words entered his mind. Slowly, he mulled them over, and I swear I saw a candlestick appear above his head.

"Aha... this proves it! He must want Belial's position as the second, but not actually the first! You're so smart, Ylvusk!"

Somewhere, deep inside the deepest blackest part of my heart, I bludgeoned my friend to death that day. I beat his head in brutally with my own claws and it felt amazing.

This idiot will be the death of me.

Part 107:

I stared in disbelief at the array of test weapons that Captain Adams was showing me.

"These... are the new weapons? These aren't even actual guns!" I pointed at the Boomstick. "It only shoots one shot at a time! And it has a six second reload!"

Adams shook his head slowly as I ranted, finally interrupting me. "Slayer, you're a smart guy. But the problem with the 'guns' that you remember is they're weak. Even the bigger bullets, they might cause some decent damage to a charging demon, but what about an Ogre? What about Trolls and other advanced monsters and demons?"

I stared intently at the weapons in front of me. Come to think of it, Adams was right. What good are bullets designed for killing humans against the monstrosities of hell? You need *stopping power* to take down a charging orc. Bleeding out monsters and demons is not an option, you need them dead as quickly as possible.

I indicated a few of the other weapons. "What about these?"

Adams nodded. "The 'Buddha Palm' and the 'Shock Lance' are still experimental. We've had some bad accidents, but with your clones nearby there haven't been any fatalities, or unhealed injuries for that matter."

Adams and I stared at the array of tools and weapons on the table in front of us quietly for a few minutes. I still couldn't believe my eyes. These are new inventions. I don't understand how they work and Adams' explanations are too technical for me, but the ideas are solid and they're performing beautifully.

Adams broke the silence. "Slayer, I've been meaning to talk to you... about your abilities."

I looked up and our eyes met. "All right. Go on."

Adams took the Crown of Solomon off his head as he spoke. "Listen, your ability that you use to clone yourself... can it be used to clone other things?"

I looked at the crown he was holding in his hand meaningfully. *Of course*. Why didn't I think of it first? That is an amazing idea.

"I... don't know? I've never tried before." I took the crown from his hand and swallowed hard as I focused my mind on it.

"*Clone.*"

And in my spare hand, a new Crown appeared! I gasped and my eyes shot open. Adams was stunned too.

"By the gods, do you understand what this means?"

I nodded rapidly. "This kind of power is dangerous."

Adams grabbed the crown from my hand as he quickly placed it on his head. He stared around the room, turning his head here and there. "Hmm. No mental map... and I feel the same as ever..."

He took the crown off and set it on the ground, breathing heavily. "It's a dud."

I nodded. "Damn. That would be too convenient."

He stared at the crown, long and hard. "You know, the Crown may be a fake... but it looks real. This might be useful in the future."

I nodded. "We might be able to fool our enemies with it somehow."

Suddenly Adams leaped to his feet as a look of shock blasted from his face. "MY GOD!"

I jumped up in surprise. "What? What?!"

He looked me in the eyes as his breathing speed increased greatly. "Clone me!"

Mine increased too! "Holy crap, Adams! You're a genius!"

"I KNOW!" His excitement was contagious.

I aimed my hand at him. "Clone!" A clone of Adams appeared. It stared ahead blankly, and instantly both our moods deflated. "Shit, he won't be of any use in the brains department."

Adams nodded as he stared the doppelganger closely, staring at its various features and whatnot. "Well, perhaps it could make for a convincing faked death if the need should arise?"

I shrugged. "Maybe. Should I, ah, kill it?"

Adams seemed horrified by the thought. "Heavens no! That would surely curse the real me! Let's keep it stored somewhere safe and tell nobody of this. It may be of use in the future."

I nodded, and we sat back down, leaving the clone to stare ahead mutely.

"Alright, now try cloning... ah! This!" Adams handed me a boomstick. I cloned it easily, it functioned perfectly. I even cloned the ammo perfectly too.

"I see now. You don't have to know how something works to clone it, but if you clone something complex, it usually has major flaws. In the case of other sentient beings, they become mute and dumb, plus they become weakened. In the case of your magical artifacts, they look exactly the same, but they lose their magical properties and become normal objects. Hmm, yes, I'm beginning to get a better idea of your abilities as time goes on. We can make use of this."

I nodded. "You tell me what to do, and I'll do it. You just make sure we win."

Adams grinned a huge beaming smile. "We aren't just going to win, we're going to absolutely devastate demonkind forever."

Part 108: Remnants

Barbatos coughed as he walked along. Flanked by a small legion of 100 monsters and demons, he had come to inspect the latest defiled site.

A gruesome scene, to be sure. More of those barbaric small spears and barbs were embedded in the bodies of his minions. Bones and blood were scattered all around the wide hallway as far as the eye could see. This had been a long fought battle, unlike the ones before it. He'd lost hundreds of lackeys.

He hacked and coughed as he leaned on his staff and stroked his long greying beard. "Accursed humans. Look at how they wound us. Have we no recourse? Have we no means of defending against their technologies?"

To be sure, these barbaric weapons would have little to no effect on a Duke class demon, such as he, but against the lower devolved minions of the labyrinth, they were super effective. Critical hits had taken out many of the bodies in the room, some demons had clearly fallen with a single shot.

Boomsticks. The reports given by a couple of imps during the first encounter with humans wielding them had been invaluable. Demons made sure to group up in wide passageways now, where a single shot couldn't take out more than one or two at a time, and they had several layers of protective magic added onto the leaders to make them take more hits, though ultimately the continuous barrage of fire by the humans made it difficult to draw near.

Barbatos stepped over the body of a large fallen Orc Captain as he made his way forwards. Finally, to his relief, he encountered some bodies of humans. "Good, we're finally managing to at least take a few of the little angels with us."

We're constantly losing, all the time. Barbatos thought to himself, as he walked past the death and chaos. *We haven't had a single conclusive win in months. Things are looking terrible.*

As he walked, he received a telepathic communication from one of the lower ranked Communication Oracles.

Barbatos, lord Diablo and the rest of the council desires your presence. You are ordered to appear before him as soon as you possibly can.

The communication cut off instantly when the voice was done 'speaking'. Barbatos growled under his breath. "I'm just a poor old demon, why can't they leave me alone for once? My knees

hurt and my bones ache. Just give me some vacation time already, I've earned a trip to the Pits."

As he continued mumbling and muttering under his breath, Barbaros turned around and headed back the way he had come from. *Being old sucks.*

* * *

It took him many ticks to finally arrive, but Barbatos finally made his appearance in the Council of 7, quickly noting a lack of a 7th Council-demon. *Interesting, where the devil did Beelzebub run off to?*

He hobbled over and stood at the end of the table, just to the side of Mephisto. "Ahem... greetings, young ones, and Master Diablo himself as well. To what do I owe the, erm, pleasure?"

Diablo smiled. "Ah, Barbatos. So good of you to join us. Go ahead and have a seat."

Barbatos glanced at the table. "My apologies, but I must decline. It would be discourteous towards Lord Beelzebub to take his seat, even if only for a moment. I may have a higher rank than he, but I always give respect to those who work hard in the Emperor's service."

Diablo paused. "No no, master Barbatos, you seem to misunderstand. You are now officially considered a member of the Council of 7. Beelzebub was actually killed, a long time ago. I'm... surprised you don't know of his passing."

Barbatos coughed, as he contemplated the words of Diablo. "Hmm, dead, is he? I hadn't heard this yet. I am old as you know, perhaps my memory is simply fading."

Barbatos slowly shuffled around the table, hobbling along on his cane until he arrived at the seat designated as his by Diablo. Interestingly, it was directly on the left hand side of Diablo, leading one to conclude it was a seat of important prestige.

Diablo nodded graciously as Barbatos took his seat. "I know you find this a great bother, and I know you hate doing hard work at your age, but the council needs your wisdom in these perilous times."

Barbatos nodded slowly, as he vacantly stared at the table in front of him. "Ah yes, it really is such a pain. But if my presence here can stop the onslaught of these... humans... then it is worth being here. A shame about Beelzebub though. He showed much promise for such a young whelp."

Diablo nodded. Bael grimaced and turned his head up towards the ceiling. "He was an arrogant little imp. Even in his Vampire form, he was weak, bested easily by a single human in combat."

Barbatos nodded slowly. "Indeed... the Slayer. I've heard tales of him from survivors of human attacks. It would seem that he has a terrifying power we cannot hope to comprehend. He

is an existential threat to our kind. A creator level threat, if you will."

Bael shrugged. "He's dangerous, for sure... but I wouldn't give him that much credit. All it will take is for one mistake, a single moment of weakness, and he will fall like all the other haughty human rulers of the past did."

Mephisto slowly shook his head as he clasped his hands under his ethereal chin and leaned on the table. "To be frank, I think you're completely wrong. Slayer possesses incredible power. We can only defend against words that target our bodies specifically, like instant death words. Things that affect the environment around us cannot be easily stopped. If he were to summon his Meteor in this realm, and he made it half as powerful as it was before, he would still destroy all of us in an instant."

Bael shrugged and sat back in his chair. "Perhaps. I will say that you did fight him, so you probably know more than I do about his abilities. Still, I should think that no matter how strong he gets, he will never defeat the First Emperor, let alone the second or the third. But the first..."

Diablo stiffened. "Quiet. Keep that talk to yourself. Only myself, Belial, and you know his true identity. Let's keep it that way."

Bael blinked his eyes slowly as he remembered the first time he had been taken to meet the first emperor. *This being is far beyond any powers Satan ever had.* He remembered feeling true fear in the face of such a mighty being. Yes, no matter how powerful he became, this was a being the Slayer would never overcome.

"Of course, my liege. To be honored with knowledge of the First Emperor's identity... only a fool would give up such knowledge so easily.

The others at the table looked on thoughtfully as they pondered who it might be.

Part 109: Blast

Lieutenant Cody and his group of 30 elite marines walked down the corridors quietly. In recent weeks, things had changed quite a bit, with the enemy preparing traps that could turn deadly if they weren't spotted in time.

Cody stared ahead, an expressionless face searching all around his group, as they walked. He was quickly rising in the military ranks, and could soon rise to the rank of captain. Of course, 'Captain' was a title that Captain Adams still used, but only because that's what everyone called him. In reality, he was more of a king... but Adams was a humble man.

Cody, however, was not. He wasn't a braggart either, but he was a man who loved war. He loved the taste of death and decay. He loved slicing, bashing, and as of recently, blasting his enemies to smithereens. He made an excellent commander though because Cody was fiercely competitive. He hated losing, even up to losing just a single man. He tried to win on all fronts, using advanced pincer movements and a technique the Slayer had mentioned in passing called "Blitzkrieg" where you simply rush through enemy lines, blasting them down before they have the ability to fight back.

But today, he had to be more cautious. As one of the weapon specialists who was able to test new weaponry, he was tasked with using the existing armory that he and his men had grown used to over the last few months, but also some improved weaponry finally released for the final testing phase before they became available for active duty use.

Cody and his team walked until they arrived at a section of the catacombs that narrowed down into a smaller hallway, leading up to a solid iron door. Cody grimaced. He hated doors. Anything could be behind them.

He turned to Saul. "You're up. Test it here, we'll see if it has any effect before we try something else."

Saul, a tall skinny man with pale skin, nodded as he walked forwards. He adjusted the new glove-type weapon on his hand. It was metallic, just like Gunther's, but less armored and bulky. It had some long stretchy tubes that went from the glove to a device he wore on his back, which gave the glove its main abilities.

Saul walked up to the door and braced himself as he aimed his Buddha Palm, as they called it, at the door. Aiming his palm forwards, he waited for the order to fire at twenty-five-percent power.

Cody raised his hand, paused for a second or two as his men stiffened their bodies.

Then he dropped his hand down. "Fire."

BOOM!

A blast of fire and hot air shot out of the well protected glove weapon as the canister inside the suit did its job. The air rushed forward, instantly encountering the door as a narrow stream, widening as it impacted against the steel frame. The door was barred and barricaded on the other side though, so it only shook mightily as the rushing air and fire came to a rapid halt. The entire process took about three seconds.

The air in the room was noticeably warmer. Saul wiped sweat off his brow with his left hand after quickly loading another shell in the back left bottom corner of the backpack suit. The process had become automatic for him thanks to hours of training. This was not just a weapon or a tool, this meant the lives of his friends and comrades, his commander, and even himself could be at stake if he failed to reload and fire when needed.

He loaded the Yellow cartridge this time, the one for 50% power. The blue cartridge was clearly not strong enough, and the orange and red cartridges might just be too much power. Not to mention Red was only for extreme emergencies. The fire and air were hot enough to dissolve organic matter and presented a major risk of killing the suit wearer. In fact, any wearer of the Buddha Palm was only outfitted with a single Red level cartridge, while having at least four oranges.

Cody wiped his own forehead, noting the sudden increased temperature in the room. "Saul, pull back. If it doesn't work on the next cartridge, we'll roast to death. Let Samantha take this one."

Saul nodded. "As you wish, Lieutenant."

He stepped back from the door as the pretty black-haired lady stepped forwards.

"Alright, go knock that flimsy door down for me, sweetheart. As soon as you do, get back and let the big boys get in there."

Samantha rolled her eyes as she faced forwards. The lieutenant didn't see it. "Please, boys will always be boys." Samantha advanced forwards, her forked tail darting around here and there as she playfully danced and skipped along towards the door. "Watch and learn, kids!"

Hooking her middle finger down with her thumb, she aimed it at the door. *Flick*. With a single finger, she smashed the door forwards, sending it blasting into the room along with whatever had been blocking it before.

Instead of retreating backwards, she boldly entered the room. "See? Should have asked me from the start."

Cody scowled. This succubus would be the death of his men.

Part 110: Holes

Samantha walked in the room, her eyes darting around, looking for enemies. She was the newest member of the Marines, and thus had the least experience of all of them. Despite that, she was exceedingly powerful, having joined the Humans because as a succubus she had... interests that aligned with humanity's.

Her battle experience would appear to be low compared to the others, but a second glance would clear up that misconception quickly. She wore very little, and compared to the marines around her decked out in medium strength armor, she was a clear target for enemies. She was scantily clad, wearing a seductive negligee made of white cotton that left little to the imagination, and her only weapon was a whip (*of course it was*) that could electrocute anything it touched.

But the whip was largely for, ahem, cosmetic reasons. She possessed a demonic level of regeneration, letting her take large amounts of damage while quickly healing her wounds, and a strong connection to the spiritual and thought energy around her. As a high class evolved demon, she had large amounts of intelligence and she spent most of it thinking of how to, eh, entrap males of certain species. Despite her looks and the threat she possessed, even she wouldn't do anything vile to a human without his permission, lest she anger the Slayer, whom she adored and was her ultimate goal of attracting.

Samantha rubbed her charcoal-skinned arms as she walked in the room. "Goodness, it certainly is chilly in here. I'm not fond of the cold."

"Cheh, maybe you ought to wear more clothing then..." Saul mumbled under his breath. She didn't hear him, or perhaps decided to ignore the comment.

The room was barren, but it had a large number of small openings which appeared to be tunnels all around inside it. The room was circular once you entered it, and something about the design of the room alarmed her.

"Boys, I think we should stay out of here. There were supposed to be demons here, and there appear to be none..." Samantha itched her forehead as she pondered the holes in the walls.

"Smells like trap." Gunther muttered as he looked around, warily. "Not like, we leave now."

Cody entered the room, leaving 5 troops outside the room to cover the entrance. He walked around, motioning for everyone to stay still. As he walked around, he felt something crackling under his boots. He looked down and picked up pieces of... *something*. It was the same color at

the floor and the walls around him, blending in with it perfectly. It was completely transparent and brittle to the touch.

As he stared at it in bewilderment, feeling the *something* in his hands but seeing nothing, Samantha walked over, rubbing her arms on her shoulders for warmth. She looped her arm through his, pulling herself against the Lieutenant, which made him fairly uncomfortable given his wife and two kids at home. Saul glanced over and scowled, but Samantha ignored him as her shivering ceased.

"Mmm, you're pretty warm. Whatcha got there?" She pointed with her other hand at the nothingness he seemed to be staring at.

"I'm not sure. It's completely transparent and it falls apart when you exert even the slightest pressure on it." Cody reached over and handed the stuff to her.

The moment she received it, a look of recognition passed over her face. "This... this is a demon egg. These are laid by a brood queen. In three hours time, they will evaporate and become thought energy. This room must be a breeding ground for imps. But... something isn't right."

Cody pulled away from her arm and immediately felt better for it as his guilt disappeared. "What do you mean, something's wrong?"

"This shell is in the final stages, but the smell of this room is wrong. And where is the brood mother? The only way these eggs could be here is if something moved them here, perhaps other demons... and..."

She stared at the ground around her thoughtfully. "Perhaps, this room is some kind of... testing room. I heard about these some ticks back. Before I joined the humans, I was in a cantina run by a friend of mine and I overheard some orcs discussing new evolutions that start before a demon's birth. But they're supposed to be highly experimental. Yes, this would explain why this room doesn't smell like an Imp breeding room and the lack of a brood mother."

Gunther was on the far side of the room, opposite the door, staring at a hole on the wall. "Me no like. Me hear... scratch sounds..."

Samantha jerked up. "Sounds? Where? From in those... holes...?" A look of horror sprouted on her face. "...We need to get out of here. Now. This was a bad idea."

A sound was suddenly audible, from deep inside many of the holes at once, sounding like the scratching of many claws running on glass. The sounds turned Saul's blood to ice.

"Commander... we need to leave. Now!"

Cody nodded energetically, and started quickly beckoning everyone out the door. As they ran, Gunther came up in the rear and stammered as he ran out the door. "Monsters! Behind!"

Saul turned around and gasped as he saw a hundred new types of demons he had never seen before swarming out of the walls, racing after their fleeing prey.

These demons would later be known as the *Gre**z*.

Part 111: Grez

Saul instantly leaped into action as he saw the terrifyingly fast monsters approaching within feet of the door. He jumped backwards, somersaulting in midair and aiming his hand at the door as he blasted his Yellow cartridge at the opening. A massive wall of fire and air, dwarfing the previous blast by a few orders of magnitude, shot out of his hand and sent the little scurrying four legged monstrosities flying backwards, smashing against the wall of their nest room.

But to Saul's horror, it seemed to do no damage to the nimble monsters at all. Neither the fire nor the impact against the wall hurt them. Their bodies were protected by a rock hard outer skin, with only small bits of their fleshy undercoat being visible in small spots on the joints. Their bodies were covered in various small and large spiked bones, varying in size and position from one monster to another. They ran on four legs, but had an additional two that sprouted up and out of their armor that looked like stabbing bones for pinning down prey in front of them so the prey couldn't escape. And their *mouths*. Their mouths were filled with five rows of razor sharp teeth, perfect for easily chewing through anything in an instant.

But the speed was the worst. They zipped along, running on walls, the ceiling, apparently able to move on any surface around them as needed.

Samantha watched as Saul's attack did nothing to the little demons, and she quickly used a spell to yank him backwards before they could grab hold of him, and her other hand waved around to create an ice wall in front of the doorway. Double spell-casting was a special ability of hers she had gained since her evolution to Elder Succubus. (Though she hated the 'elder' part of her name, since she was clearly a youthful young princess.)

In a flash, the enemies ganged up on the ice, pounding their bodies against the wall as they quickly leaped back and body slammed it over and over again.

But it was enough. Giving the marines a few seconds to quickly form up, they took their positions. Cody glanced down at his belt and pulled out a medallion Captain Adams had given him before the mission. *Yellow Team is the most successful team of our weapons testers. If things get dire, use this. But only use in an emergency, it will break after a single use.* Captain Adams always looked out for his troops.

Within 15 seconds, the creepers smashed through the ice wall and tumbled to the ground, rapidly righting themselves and charging forwards.

"FIRE!" I bellowed, as three of my best marksman fired their Boomsticks. Three bolts lanced forwards at insane speeds, piercing the thick armor of the monsters as they stumbled and fell to the ground.

But they didn't die.

It seemed to visibly slow them down, but they showed no signs of pain, no screams of agony, nothing. And the shots didn't go all the way through, they only stuck halfway inside the beasts. These monsters weren't just small and fast, they were *tough*.

Gunther charged forwards, blasting into the first monster, his rocket fist smashing it in the face with incredible force. The monster staggered back, falling down and slumping dead to the floor. One down, more than a hundred to go.

I gazed in horror, as the wave of monsters charged at us. This is it, we will die here for sure. I have to use it.

Grabbing the medallion, I raised it in the air and shouted.

"Apollo!"

And instantly, my entire group appeared in the throne room of Hero City's castle. Everyone stumbled forwards and fell to the ground ungracefully as their surroundings instantly changed. Captains Adams happened to be entering the room as we arrived, and gasped as he saw our sudden appearance. Just as the shock from that was about to fade, he gasped again when he realized how we had appeared.

"You used Apollo's Medallion?! What the devil happened to make you have to do that?! I said it was for use only in emergencies!"

I stared at the ground as the fear of the previous moments finally started to fade.

"Trust me, Adams. You're not going to believe what just happened to us."

Part 112:

I sat, staring at the ground as Adams and the Yellow Team discussed what had happened only a few minutes ago. Receiving an appearance request from Adams, I teleported here in a jiffy and was experiencing many emotions as they described what they had gone through.

This is not good.

Beelzebub had told me, many years ago, about the rules of this place. I haven't spoken to him in a while as he's busy aiding the intelligence offices with various strategic information regarding demons, but I got the gist of what he had told me.

This labyrinth has rules, and they were written in (figurative) stone by the original First Emperor, Satan, when he created it. Beelzebub knew the rules, but not how long ago they were made or how this place came to be made. Compared to the dukes and kings of this labyrinth, he truly was a small fry, young when contrasted with their timelessness. His truly important and useful knowledge lay in the weaknesses of various demons he had met and their relationships with one another, as well as their home worlds that the more influential ones ruled over. He was how we had been able to locate Mephisto's homeworld.

One of the labyrinth's most sacred rules was never allowed to be broken. *Demons are not allowed to evolve more than 100 times, and they are not allowed to evolve to any new forms other than what is already known.*

The creation of this rule made perfect sense to me. If other demons could evolve, they might one day overthrow Satan if they reached a new unique form and gained some incredible previously unknown ability.

But in the context of the recent invasion of the labyrinth by humans, there were many who wanted to circumvent that rule. Therefore, they must be hiding secret mutation and evolution chambers where they forcefully spawn new types of demons to combat our troops.

And if they're so desperate they're willing to risk death, that must mean we are *winning* this war.

But we're not.

This new monster whom we've coined the Grez... it is unlike any before it. We can't kill it with a single shot. Only Gunther with his tremendous strength could do such a thing. It would be trivial for me, but for a normal human, they would be mincemeat in the face of such demons.

I need to find a way for the general population to combat these. I have operated for ten years under the assumption that the enemies we know of are the ones we must prepare for, but since newer horrors may emerge, I need to be careful. Very careful. If they evolve some other new monster when we least expect it, we could suffer some bad losses.

My mind blanked for a minute and I suddenly felt dizzy. Gah... I've been feeling like this every now and again for a great while now but... this one suddenly hit hard. I grabbed some water and swallowed it quickly, my mind returning to normal. *Odd.*

"...ur opinion? Slayer?" Adams was speaking to me. I jerked my head up from the floor and quickly glanced around at the faces looking at me.

"Huh? What did you say?"

Adams cleared his throat quietly. "Ah, I just asked what was your opinion? How should we deal with this new breed of monster?"

I paused for a few seconds as I thought about it. "Hng... perhaps I should simply create more clones. A single clone should travel with every single battalion and regiment, every group that enters the maze. If we encounter the Grez, have the commander order the clone to take any action necessary. They should... *hopefully* be able to at the least slow down the Grez long enough for the troops to take cover. Ideally the clone will eliminate them."

Saul nodded thoughtfully as he rubbed his hands together. His backpack for the Buddha Palm weapon was sitting on the floor behind him, and he seemed to feel relief at taking it off. Unlike Gunther, he didn't seem to treat it like it was a precious part of his body. "Hey, Slayer, I've been wondering for a while, is there any issue with all these clones you've made?"

I shrugged. "So far, no issues. They're like having a small army of wordsmiths anywhere you need them."

Saul hesitated, as if considering his next words carefully. "I mean, don't you feel... unnerved? All these copies of you, mutely walking around the city? Every citizen here knows your face by heart for sure. And they just follow orders, like robots, but they're... you know... human. Doesn't that bother you in the slightest?"

I shook my head. "I don't view them as human. They're just tools to be used in the war against the demons. They're convenient and they serve their purpose."

Saul lowered his eyes. "Yeah... I guess so. It's not really my business, so whatever." He wiped his black hair out of his face as he slowly stood up to leave. "Captain Adams, Slayer, always a pleasure. I need to go shower now that I've concluded my part in this briefing. Have a good day."

I nodded thoughtfully and waved as he left. Human? My clones certainly look like humans, but they don't act like it at all. To be honest, they act more like puppets. They just do as I tell them to and that is that. I do constantly worry about what would happen if a commander went rogue and commanded the clones to attack the city with a meteor or something, but I've given them the order that my commands take precedence over Adams whose take precedence over the top generals and so on and so forth. I think it would be fixed quickly if such a thing happened.

I turned back to Adams as my thoughts concluded. "Captain, I've been meaning to ask, what exactly did the Medallion of Apollo function like? Can you explain in detail?"

Adams hesitated as he thought. "Well, it seemed to instantly transfer not just Cody, but all those designated as his subordinates, to this castle. I don't know how it knew the throne room was the place he wanted to return to, but it did."

I nodded slowly. The Crown had told me when I found it what the effects were, but I didn't want to waste such a valuable item. I found it strange that Adams would give it to a fairly low ranking officer, but it turned out to be the perfect use. His brains border on the edge of predicting the future at this point.

"What about the other artifacts I found? Any good uses for them?"

Adams stared at me. "Maybe. They're pretty situational though, it's a tough call. Where do you find these anyway? We have thousands of troops scouring the labyrinth and you are the only one to ever find these objects of incredible magical power."

I shifted my eyes away from him and stared blankly back at the table. "I don't know, Adams. I don't know. I've had the ability to see them since I entered here. They light up like a glowing beacon when I'm within a certain range of them, and I just follow my senses until I get there."

Adams nodded. "Can your clones sense them?"

I rocked back and forth in my seated position as I considered it. "Possibly, maybe even probably, but it's hard to tell."

Adams raised an eyebrow, something I could just barely perceive with my spherical vision. "It's worth a shot, I'd say. The more we can gather, the better."

Adams concluded the meeting eventually and we all went on our way. There's a lot to think about, but this new Grez menace... it will weigh heavily on my mind in the coming days.

Part 113:

Cody staggered back as he saw the Grez running around the curve ahead of him. "Shit! Grez! Clone B21, attack at will!"

Clone B21, staring ahead lifelessly as always, suddenly jerked into motion, silently running up to the front of the group.

"Slow!"

The clone cast a spell, and then a split second later Cody thought he heard the clone say something else that sounded like "Speed" but he couldn't be sure.

Ahead of him, something astonishing happened. The clone started moving around at close to the speed of sound, making thunderous noise as he blasted around at speeds Cody couldn't even keep track of.

In an instant, 5 Grez died before Cody could register their bodies taking hits. Icicles formed out of midair, flying into their squishy neckline (A key weak spot noted by autopsies) and impaling them into the ground.

There were 5 explosions within two seconds, the members of his marines group were feeling dazed watching it. They had heard rumors of the power of Slayer, but this was his autonomous *clone*. How much more powerful would the main body be?

And as they took a moment to think for themselves *this is too easy*, the clone suddenly came to a stop and smashed into the ground in front of them, his body crumpling up into a terrifyingly broken resting position.

The Grez had halted their advance as they... waited? They stared ahead blankly at the group of humans. Only ten Grez left, the other 15 had been killed by the clone. But that was still a lot of Grez.

What happened to the clone?! Cody spared a glance from the Grez to the body smashed into a broken mess just twenty feet away. Had something hit it? He didn't know much about Slayer's actual abilities other than that he was a 'wordsmith' so it might be anything at all. Maybe he moved too fast and tripped on a rock?!

Cody ignored those thoughts. The Grez were still here. Just as he was about to issue an order to his men, the *Slayer himself* appeared right next to the corpse of his clone. The Slayer completely ignored the broken body next to him, raised a hand up and said a single word.

" **Dissolve!** "

Instantly the Grez in front of him wordlessly turned into puddles of blood and bone, quickly covering the floor around them in their disgusting cocktail of internal body parts. A smell erupted from their liquified corpses and blasted out all around them, resembling the smell of every kind of rotten food known to mankind mixed with horrible smells involving rotting body parts. Three men behind Cody instantly fell down to their knees, heaving on the floor.

Cody and most of the others barely managed to hold the contents of their stomachs, and even the Slayer was visibly sickened by it. The Slayer quickly jerked his hand up and yelled another word. " **Deodorize!** "

The smell vanished just as quickly as it came, to everyone's highest relief. After a few minutes of soul searching and stuffing his inner contents back down where they came with his mind, Cody spoke to the Slayer.

"Slayer, you came at the perfect time. It was about to get hairy here. How did you know to come?"

Slayer stared ahead blankly, not looking at me or anything else, which made sense given his blindness. "My clone died. When they die, I can sense their death. It feels like a bee stinging my brain... hard to put into words. I just transfer over to their corpse and see what happened."

He bent down and placed his hand on various areas of his clone's body. "I used to be able to follow my clone's actions in real time, but there's too many of them now. I've lost count. I only know when they die anymore because of the mental feedback I receive. All the constant thoughts streaming into my head made me have to silence them."

He stood up again. "This isn't good. This clone died because of overexertion. He used 'slow' which puts a tremendous stress on the body, and then used 'speed' which increases the stress a hundredfold. By moving around at high speed and draining his energy even faster with spells, he destroyed his own internal body with G-forces. I never use Slow and Speed together unless I'm wearing the crown so at least I can perceive damage to my body."

Slayer rubbed his head while he spoke. After some time, he rose to his feet and aimed his hand at the body. " *Reintegrate.* "

The clone instantly disappeared, it vanished so fast the men and I almost thought it had never even been there. Slayer rubbed his closed eyes with his fingers, and then summoned another clone.

"Slayer, are you doing okay?" Saul stepped forward and spoke to the Slayer, a look of concern on his face.

Slayer shrugged. "Yeah, I'm fine I guess. Just... tired these days. Very tired. Try not to let this one die, alright? I'm very busy in the capital these days."

Cody nodded. "Sorry that you had to come here personally, Slayer. But we're thankful for your abilities. You've given us a new hope for the future. For humanity."

Slayer nodded slowly as he stared ahead blankly. "Yeah... thanks, Lieutenant Cody. You keep doing what you need to. We have a species to save."

And with that, Slayer recalled himself to the castle, disappearing in the blink of an eye. I looked over at the new clone. They resemble him perfectly in appearance, wearing the exact clothes he wore when he summoned them, but the empty and robotic personality breaks the uncanny valley illusion.

"Alright, clone, let's go." I paused. I don't have a name for this clone. Slayer forgot to name it before he left. Right, ah, your name will be Clone B-" I paused. It just seemed wrong to give the clone a designation ID. This was a human in front of me, even if it didn't act like one. "...Your new designation will be Hope. You and your kind are the hope of our species, so I think it's only fitting that you have a name befitting that station."

The clone stared ahead vacantly. But... for the most fleeting moment of time, I could swear that I saw a hint of a smile pass the corner of his lips.

"Alright, boys, and Samantha. Let's head out."

Part 114:

Aaron rubbed the spot on his chest as his breath came in ragged gasps. He was too old for this. Having fought demons for 40 straight years of his life, he didn't have the strength to fight at full power anymore.

He gripped his signature sword with his right hand, as he rubbed his chest with his left. His shield had been torn out of his left hand minutes before and lay broken in half mere feet away. Aaron wheezed and coughed as he faced down the monstrosity that towered before him.

Satan.

This demon was the leader of all of them. Satan was the one who commanded behind the scenes and directed his minions where to go and how to attack. Having evolved beyond the form of Oracle, he now left that work to others and fought directly on the battlefield itself, reaping massive spiritual power from his foes when he slayed them.

Satan licked his lips in anticipation of the power he would soon gain.

"King Aaron, a pleasure to see you, as always. How is your father? Is he *ahead* of the curve?" Satan grinned as his pun made Aaron glare at him in rage.

"Vile demon! It was you that killed my father, wasn't it? I have heard your name spoken of in screams of agony by demons we've captured and tortured. You are the leader of these foul monstrosities, so if I kill you, then..." Aaron grimaced. It wouldn't be easy to kill Satan. Even in a fair duel, Aaron was old now, much weaker than in his prime when he had been crowned king of all humans on Earth by Gabriel himself, while Satan was a highly evolved demon, far above the others of his kind. To top it off, there were hundreds of cackling and grinning minions standing at the sidelines of the throne room, waiting for the moment to strike. It was hopeless.

Satan stared unemotionally at the ant before him. This human had been a thorn in his side for too many years. "You've delayed my inevitable conquest, human. For that, you will pay. I have killed all your guards, your wives, and all your children as well. Your family line ends here, as will you."

Aaron staggered to his feet as he faced the monster in front of him. Satan towered over all humans, standing a massive 9 feet in height. Even Diablo and Lucifer were small fry compared to Satan's almighty power.

Aaron quietly chuckled, and Satan perked his ears up as he wondered what the human was thinking. "Heh heh... all my children too? You are truly a demon. Attacking the innocents who

have done nothing to you. But... there is one you know nothing of. A grandchild."

Satan nodded thoughtfully as he evenly kept his expression neutral. "Oh? You have a baby hidden away somewhere, then? Thank you for the information. I'll be sure to kill it before the next moon rises tonight."

Aaron laughed. "Ha... haha... you can't kill him. That child is protected by those you fear most. He is not a baby either, he is a stout young man, the kind of man my own father had wished me to become. Even when you strike me down, he will become more powerful than you can possibly imagine. His power will eclipse my own."

Satan smiled and brushed off Aaron's words with a wave of his hand. "Strong words, for a weak old man. Humans were created as a joke, a weak parasitical bunch that only wish to rape one another, rape the lands, rape their enemies, and tear everything to pieces. You think we are monsters? We are only fighting to end the tyranny of your kind."

Aaron grimaced as a spasm of pain swept around inside his chest, and he coughed mightily. "We seem to be made to suffer. It's our lot in life. You demons may think you're fighting the oppressors, but you are no better than we are. Even if you kill all the humans, you will merely take our place as the devourers of the world."

Satan stood up completely straight, rising to his full height as he cracked the joints in his 7 fingered talons. "Ah, humans. Experts in wordplay, failures on the battlefield. I will kill you now, so I hope you've *prayed* to your gods to come and save you."

Aaron shook his head. "I am old now. I do not wish to be saved. If I must die, dying on the battlefield is an honorable way to pass. But I will leave you with a single warning, *monster*. My grandchild is unlike any human you have faced before. He is the combination of a great bout of experimentation. He is the one who will destroy all of your kind. If I am considered a strong human, he will be known as a God. He will force you to your knees in battle and you will beg him for mercy, but he will have none. You killed everyone in his family, and he will kill everyone in yours."

Satan nodded as a wicked smile sprouted on his face. "Excellent. I like that spirit. You will be a satisfying way to end my day. Given your accomplishments on the field of battle, I will honor you with a single question. What is the name of this child you are so proud of? I wish to know before I meet him on the field of battle."

Aaron's pained expression disappeared as a grin took over his face. " *Hercules*. Remember his name, and let it haunt you in your dreams, for your days are numbered. He is the son of one of my daughters and a god from the heavens, a bastard child conceived in secret. But of all my children, he is the one whom I have loved the most. He is the only one left, and someday, when

you face him and he defeats you, he will be known by a title none before have been named. *Hero.* "

Satan cocked an eyebrow. "The gods must be getting desperate. Demi-human bastard children? The frailties of a human diluting the power of gods? I'll be lucky if he lasts five minutes against me in battle. But I will remember our conversation. You may take that with you, to the grave."

Aaron nodded. "So it was written. So it shall be done."

A minute later, Aaron, the first of the Great Kings of old, was struck down by the foul leader of the Demons. He came to be known as the Great Unifier, for his ability to unite all people of all colors and creeds together in solidarity against their greatest enemy. None after him were able to achieve this. However, his legacy shaped the will and life of generations of humans after him.

But his grandson would be the one to change everything.

Part 115: Hercules

Satan cackled maniacally as he and his demons threw another mighty feast of the ages. Slaves they had captured from the filthy humans served up platters filled with cooked and uncooked remains of the thousands of humans the demons had butchered since the death of Aaron. It had been five years since then, and with no king to lead them, the fall of Man was sure to be soon. As the humans served food, their bodies trembling as they held the mangled corpses of friends and lovers and family, they stifled their pent up rage and tears as demons kicked and whipped them, stoically trying to hold up even a tiny bit of self-esteem despite the jeering and insults.

Satan slapped his knees while he roared with laughter as his general, glowing with pride, showed his fearless leader the latest results. 60% of all humans on the Earth were now dead. There were still some untouched holdouts in the continent later to be known as Africa and there were some weak tribes scattered throughout the north and south Americas (As they later came to be known), but for the most part, there no longer existed any humans that could defy him.

Still... as Satan laughed, a thought kept creeping back into his mind. *Who was that 'Hercules' that King Aaron, the Great Unifier, warned me about? Was it a great bluff to get me to lower my guard? Probably, but I just have a feeling...*

They roared again with laughter as Diablo cracked a horrifying joke about how a human with his guts splayed on the floor might resemble an imp at birth, and as they laughed, a demon suddenly burst into his dining hall, smashing the doors to the side as he breathlessly screamed. "SIRE! SIRE! We're being SLAUGHTERED!!!"

The noise in the room slowly subsided as demons turned to look at the messenger, but Satan had already stopped laughing. His face betrayed no emotions, but inside many feelings roiled around, summoning themselves in an instant. *Fascination. Wonder. Curiosity. Horror. Fear.*

Satan leaped to his feet, as he slapped the drink out of one of his loyal generals' claws. "Barbatos, drop the grog and get to the war room *now*."

Barbatos started to protest, but then shrugged as he hopped along beside the Emperor. *Whatever, once we deal with the pests, I'll get more of the filthy stuff later, hehe.*

* * *

Satan stood on a rock overlooking the battlefield. This wasn't right. There were a few thousand humans out there, but they were wearing strange metallic clothing, with swords made of a material he had not seen before. *Longswords* he had heard them called. And they wore odd

metallic hats that covered their entire head. But even weirder, their left hands held nonsensical flat round boards, and the humans seemed to be using them to deflect attacks. Despite their apparent size and bulk, the humans seemingly had no trouble wielding them.

Ahead of them, a single blond haired man, standing 7'2" in height, wearing very little armor, and wielding no weapons or tools of any sort. But this human, the one who made himself an open and obvious target, was terrifyingly powerful. He zipped and dashed here and there, moving so fast none of the demons could lock onto him. His fists acted as if they were made of iron, pounding through the carapaces of hydras, dark-walkers, scythers, and various monsters alike. Nothing could touch him. When he hit a demon, the demon was hurled backward, usually breaking their neck instantly.

And despite saying no words as he rampaged around, his warriors clad in metal moved as a single mind. Without speaking or motioning to one another, they continuously fended off attacks from the rear and sides as if they had omnipresent shared vision. Nothing escaped them.

Satan stared, baffled at the furious war machine ravaging his demons, as imp messengers near his feet scurried up to him on his arrival.

"Emperor Satan! Great leader! We are dying by the thousands! We need your guidance to subdue the humans! We haven't managed to kill even a single one yet!"

Satan's jaw dropped as they delivered the horrifying news. *Not a single human?! Had they somehow evolved into a new species?! Since when were humans this capable at war?! Not even Aaron possessed armies of this caliber, and these warriors of the light had appeared from nowhere!*

And just as Satan was about to deliver his orders, he halted. Up, in the sky, he saw something that made his breath catch in his throat.

A massive angel, a size he had never before seen in his life. As a demon, angels were his most hated enemy, well beyond a hatred of humans who were his oppressors. But in his many years of fighting the angelic scourge, he had never seen something like this.

The angel took of so much of the horizon that he had not even realized it was there at first. It must have been ten miles in size in various directions, and the wingspan seemingly bent around the Earth itself. It held a massive staff in its hand, and seemed to be casting a *very* complex spell.

Just as Satan realized it was casting a spell, the angel finished.

A beam of immense size and power *blasted* into the ground, emanating from the top of his staff and devouring all demonic life caught inside it. It dealt no damage to the Earth or to the humans if they were caught inside it, but any demon caught inside *evaporated* into mist before they had a chance to react, and it moved all over the battlefield, hunting as if it had a mind of its own. *The Holy Beam of Heavenly Destruction.*

The beam of light fired for twenty seconds straight, killing nearly 20,000 demons in that tiny span of time. Satan fell to his knees as a nearby oracle emotionlessly delivered the report. He had now lost 50,000 minions. And the humans? Zero.

"Retreat." Satan spoke numbly, his voice almost a whisper. "Flee... into the... burrow." Satan failed to make coherent thoughts as he witnessed the awe inspiring presence of what he later came to find out was the first Cosmos Class Angel, *Gabriel*.

These humans have won this battle. But I will be back. And when I do, they will pay for their genocide of my demons.

And as those thoughts crossed his mind, the blonde human leading the others stopped in his tracks and silently stared at Satan. An icy face of hatred and revenge crossed over his eyes.

Hercules. Satan would find rest impossible for the near future, as that face gave him his first feeling of a true nightmare.

Part 116: Secrets

Gabriel, now towering over the leader of the gods, Kronos, bowed, his massive body almost seeming like he was instead kneeling down to try and see the tiny figure underneath him.

"My king, I return with good tidings."

Kronos smiled broadly. "Of course! I should expect nothing less! How did the results of the battle turn out?"

Gabriel beamed positive emotions, but kept his smile modest. "A total rout, my lord. We destroyed tens of thousands of the demons, and they fled due to Satan's direct orders."

Kronos, still smiling, nodded as he pondered the outcome. "Satan himself gave the order?"

"Yes, my liege."

"Hmm. Satan has never once retreated in battle. He must have been terrified. How many humans did we lose?"

Gabriel paused. "You may find this difficult to believe. Under the guidance of the son of Zeus, there were zero human fatalities."

Kronos' smile evaporated, as he stared up at Gabriel in awe. "Zero? That can't be possible."

"It is a fantastical tale, to be sure, but not a single human died on that day. In fact, thanks to Hercules special ability, the troops had shared vision of each other and fought as one. They received nary even a single scratch."

Kronos stared stonily. All hint of positive emotion was gone. "While that is certainly good for now, that is a fearsome and decisive defeat. Such power and total victory has not been witnessed for ages." The king turned away, now staring at the ground. "I feel a sense of fear now. One as strong as Hercules... he is a threat, a terrifying threat. Zeus is clearly a lower god I have underestimated. His love affairs put us all in peril."

Gabriel nodded knowingly. "Yes, I met Zeus once. He is reclusive, living deep inside the bowels of Olympus. Sometimes, there are rumored to be booming sounds in the deep, but too many fear him to enter his abode. I would certainly advise caution, my lord."

Kronos nodded, as he mulled the thoughts over in his head. "Tell me, Gabriel. Have you ever considered the merits of the three factions involved in this Great War?"

Gabriel stared down at his king, unsure of how to respond. "I don't know to what you refer."

Kronos made a sweeping gesture with his hands. "You are my friend, and my closest confidante. What I am about to discuss with you shall never leave this chamber. Am I clear?"

Gabriel nodded slowly. *This must be serious*, he thought to himself. Using his immense spiritual power, he carefully concentrated on his body, shrinking himself down to a smaller form, about the same size as his king, perhaps a head taller. "Before you continue, we should go somewhere private. There are many prying ears that may be listening."

Kronos nodded. "A sound idea."

* * *

They arrived in the grand personal chambers of His Majesty, and they took seats opposite each other at a small table, made entirely of marble. The seats were very large, much too large for a normal angel, but for Kronos and Gabriel, beings that stood over thirty feet tall, the chairs were the perfect size.

Kronos sipped a rich golden liquid, a secret broth of heaven, made from the pure spiritual energy of passed beings who had perished in battle.

"Gabriel, I want you to consider my words carefully. This information is secret, known only to some high ranking angels, and even then the full details are only known to me. You will be the second."

Gabriel nodded slowly, as he thoughtfully rolled two small orbs of energy around in his hand. The motion calmed him, helping to put him in a meditative and receptive state of mind.

"What do you suppose the differences are between the three major players in this Great War?"

Gabriel stared blankly at his king. "I suppose the differences- hm. Well, angels can fly, only certain demons can, and humans cannot."

Kronos rolled his eyes. "Alright. That's one difference, I suppose. Go on."

Gabriel, one to usually contain his emotions, blushed noticeably at the king's obvious irritation. "Well, I guess another would be the appearances of the three races. Demons have reddened skin, humans range in tones, and angels are-"

Kronos sighed and held up his hand to halt Gabriel. "You're missing the big picture. You're thinking of the obvious differences. Let's start with an important difference. *How the three races live*. Angels live in heaven, while the humans and demons are on Earth."

Gabriel nodded as he twirled the orbs in his hand thoughtfully.

"Because angels are separated, we are essentially indifferent to the suffering of the humans below us. And since we do not directly interact with humans very often, they view us as omnipotent beings that only appear in times of great calamity. But that is not the case. Despite the divide between our world and theirs, we are intricately linked with the fate of humans and many other lesser beings on Earth. And do you know why?"

Gabriel shifted his gaze to the ground. "No, my liege. I know not."

Kronos lowered his voice. "We require thought energy from the lower races. Not just to increase our power, but to simply survive. We need no sustenance, and we are immortal, but without thought energy and spiritual energy, we will lose our immortality."

Gabriel jerked his head back up. "Lose it?! How can such a-"

Kronos quickly shushed him. "Silence, you fool. This is the highest level of secrecy. If this information were to slip to the demons, we would be at a major disadvantage tactically."

Gabriel nodded quickly. "Yes, yes, m-my apologies."

Kronos recovered his thoughts and spoke again. "There's more. You have to look at the motivations of everyone involved in this war. Demons are our enemies, since in the past we had enslaved them before the humans were around, and forced the demons to give us thought energy to survive. But demons also despise humans. Humans were originally a species lower than demons, and have risen quickly in intelligence and spiritual power. When they rose, they started stepping on and attacking the demons. This built up a great resentment between the two."

Gabriel stared ahead quietly. This much he knew. All angels knew this.

Kronos indicated himself with his hand. "The reason I am the king of the gods is known to few. It's not just because I am a descendant of the Titans. It's because unlike you angels, I do not require spiritual energy to stay immortal, I can simply ingest it to increase my power infinitely. I also can generate my own energy, and I can devour the dark energy of slain demons, something no angel can do."

Gabriel leaned forwards, his eyes intently showing his interest. "My liege, you are truly a mighty king. You must be giving me this information for a reason. I should expect that you know I will never betray you."

Kronos nodded. "I want to be honest with you. You are now the only being mighty enough to kill me. Your ascension to Cosmos Class makes you the most powerful being in existence. Even I fear you somewhat..." Kronos voice trailed off as his gaze seemed to wander past Gabriel, looking through him as if he weren't there.

"My king, I would never-" Gabriel stared down at the table. So this is why. This is why he had been summoned here. The king feared him. "We have been friends for eons, brothers at that. Even if I were mind controlled to betray you, I would cut out my own soul afterwards..."

"Yes, I know you would." Kronos smiled gently, an expression Gabriel had never seen before. "I have been alone at the top for generations of humans and demons now. Nobody I could speak to, nobody I could trust. You alone are truly my only friend."

Gabriel stared at his king, emotions swirling inside him.

A few moments passed as both of them were deep in thought. Kronos broke the silence. "Let's continue. The differences between the races are vast. The demons never posed a threat to us, but those few short years ago, something happened. Satan somehow gained the ability to evolve, and to force his body to mutate rapidly. Since then, he has mutated many, many times. The terrifying thing about demons is thus: They are immortal, as are we, but they require no thought or spiritual energy to stay alive forever."

"And even moreso, they have the ability to breed and create new life. Angels do not. Gods can, but if a god mates a thousand times, only one of those has a chance at producing offspring. When it comes to vitality and replenishing our numbers, we are at an incredible disadvantage. And this is where humans come in. Because angels are finite, and their numbers are lowering all the time, humans are our only means of bolstering our forces. They are- I should not say 'cattle', but similar to cattle. Because humans can create many more of their kind, they are our real forces in the fight against the demons. I try not to spare angels if I do not have to."

Gabriel interrupted. "Sire, if what you say is true, I still find it morally reprehensible that you would let humans be slaughtered. What reason could you have for this?"

Kronos stared at Gabriel evenly. "Let's try a mental exercise. Which is more reprehensible? Ending the life of a being that would have lived for an eternity, or ending the life of a being that would die of old age in a short span of time anyways?"

Gabriel hesitated, still wanting to take the high ground, but he couldn't bring himself to do it. "I suppose the being of unlimited life would lose much more."

Kronos nodded. "Yes. And there is still more. All angels were created at the beginning of time by the Creator, the Original, the Unknowable. When he vanished, many angels died simply as a result of a lack of thought energy. My research indicated that in the beginning there may have been septillions of angels, but an unthinkable number of them gave their existences up in order to create the first form of thought energy in order to save the rest of their race. Today, only tens of millions remain. That number may be huge, but humans and demons alike would readily out-breed us quickly if either one actually won this war."

Gabriel audibly gasped. "You mean we have to keep the number of humans, our allies, low? As *well* as the demons?!"

Kronos nodded. "As big of a threat as the demons are, we cannot afford to eradicate them. We need humans and demons to keep fighting. We need them to hate each other, but still coexist with one another. What do you suppose would happen if we simply overwhelmed and killed all the demons off? Simply put, humans would no longer have a mortal enemy. Their killing instinct would turn against us, they would stop praying to us for protection, and they would begin attacking us. With no thought energy being gained from them, and with no other enemies to keep their numbers at bay, we would lose this war in an instant."

Gabriel slumped in his chair. *By the gods*. This news was universe shattering. He had never thought in these terms before. He gazed at Kronos in wonder. This being, this was no mere Titan. If he had come out and stated that he was the Original One, the Creator, Gabriel would undoubtedly believe him.

"My liege, how can we- why... I can't..." Words escaped his grasp.

Kronos nodded sagely. "Now you understand, *brother*." He put heavy emphasis on the last word. "You cannot escape your fate now. You and I are bound together. We have a sacred duty to keep hold of the balance of power in this universe. If I were ever to be killed somehow, and some young fool took the throne, things would end badly for all the races."

Gabriel nodded and spoke quietly. "That, my king, is the understatement of all eternity."

Part 117:

Diablo and Barbatos stood side by side on Diablo's balcony at the Castle of Terror. Having recently left another boring meeting, they were relaxing and enjoying the view of a pure black sky, with no life visible anywhere around them.

Barbatos broke the silence. "Slayer. He has been a thorn in the side of demons for too long now. Why do we continue to let him exist?"

Diablo stared vacantly at the sky. "I'm not sure. He's a threat, to be sure... but... when it all comes down to it, we demons have really lost our way."

Barbatos blinked slowly and turned to look at Diablo. "I'm older than any living demon, and I'm not even sure of what you mean. When have we ever had it better than we do now?"

Diablo slowly sighed. "Not... 'better'. It's just that we've lost our purpose. I remember when we lived for the thrill of the killing. We used to fight incredible battles for survival, we used to really let go and have a little fun tearing things to pieces, you know? And now that Slayer is here, humanity once again is becoming a threat."

Barbatos nodded. "I see. You are... bored, then?"

Diablo nodded. "I remember the great First Emperor Satan... a terror of a demon, one who ominously stood over all beings around him. Even the archangels grew to fear his destructive power. He was... an inspirational leader."

Barbatos pondered this. "Yes. I evolved after he did, despite being his senior. It was almost amusing, to see a young whelp rise up to become greater than his predecessors. How he was defeated by a little girl... it... it baffles me." Barbatos lowered his gaze as he stared down at the sprawling demonic city below him. "His power is, of course, now second to the current first emperor but... he had many qualities the current one lacks as well."

Diablo nodded. "Well, in the meantime, your plan to unleash those little horrors is working splendidly. Once again, we are outpacing the humans. How do you suppose they will respond?"

Barbatos shrugged. "I still feel vile that we broke Satan's most sacred rule. To destroy that rule absolutely, just so we could toy with humans... have we no shame?"

Diablo chuckled slightly. "Shame? Shame is for the weak, the petty, the righteous. As demons, we can't afford the luxury of shame. We simply exist to win. In the end, with Satan gone, we should start breaking some rules, letting loose a little. What point are the rules if we end up in a menial, tedious existence?"

"You speak the truth. Rules were made to be broken. When we were just little imps running around, all we did was break rules." Barbatos closed his eyes as memories flooded through his mind.

Suddenly, Diablo grew a huge grin. "Hehehe... yes... let's break some more rules. In fact... let's break *all* the rules."

Barbatos silently stared at the blackness inside his eyes. "You truly are a devil."

Part 118:

Things are getting complicated.

I rubbed my eyes as I sat down at the table and started to eat the breakfast Phoebe had cooked for me a few minutes ago. Bacon, eggs, and some interesting red and green stuff I hadn't seen before, all summoned with my power and cooked by Phoebe.

I feel *tired*.

I'm stretched thin nowadays, constantly teleporting between the labyrinth and Hero City, and constantly having to replace clones killed in battle by the Grez means I sleep more than I used to. Ten years ago, I was able to stay awake for eight months at a time because I was always buffing myself with 'Stamina' and simply resting myself with a spell, but I don't have the energy to do that now.

And I sleep a lot. I slept for 14 hours last night, and that was a shorter night. As my thought and spiritual energy supply becomes bigger and bigger, recovering it when it's empty takes longer and longer. But, at least it's worth it.

Hero city is booming. I explained the basic fundamentals of electricity to Captain Adams, and he started running with it. Now we have 24 clones, four days worth of summons, constantly resting and then waking up to summon coal and oil and gasoline all the time.

But, this is interesting. I myself cannot summon either of those three things. I can't wrap my head around the atomic structure of their composition, yet my 24 clones can. Adams named them EN-1, EN-2, etc, since they manage the Energy sector of the city. I just don't get it. How can my clones summon oil, or gas, or anything else I can't? Aren't they supposed to be inferior, stupid, weakened versions of myself?

And speaking of inferior, everything about myself is beginning to feel inferior. I keep having minor and major slips of memory. I went outside half dressed this morning, only realizing when Phoebe blushed awkwardly at me. Luckily, it was the top half that I had forgotten, heh.

But... despite my issues, the war effort is booming. The Grez were a significant challenge at first, but by using a variety of spells and weapons that freeze them in place, we're able to cut their mobility down to zilch and defeat them efficiently now. Things are... looking up.

I just can't shake this feeling, this odd feeling that something is not right in the labyrinth. For a few years now, that feeling that used to plague me day in and day out, that feeling of being *watched*, it no longer seems to afflict me. Perhaps whoever was watching me is now confused by

the presence of all my clones. Maybe that being has lost the scent of me and is confused by identical spiritual energy coming from all places at once.

I just don't know anymore. I don't know anything.

* * *

Adams smiled at me as I entered his War Room once again. I was stunned to see an incredible moving hologram floating in midair above the table. It was a hologram of the *labyrinth* and it shifted around based on the current makeup of the place at any given moment in time.

"Adams..." I gasped as I took the sight in. "How did you... when, wha-...?!"

Adams smiled as he absorbed my reaction. "Like it? There was a promising young recruit with a large amount of technical know-how we rescued from an advanced world while you were sleeping. I let him borrow the Crown of Solomon for a few hours, and he managed to create this exact image you see here. It's fully manipulable, zoomable, and-"

I cut him off as the smile on my face instantly disappeared. "Adams. You... let someone else... 'borrow' the crown? Do you realize just how dangerous that is?"

Adams halted his sentence as my gaze went from lighthearted to serious. "I mean, yes, it could have been dangerous, but I had four clones standing nearby in case he tried anything, and as you can see the ends justified the means! Now you will be able to wear the Crown into battle more often while I use this to plot strategy!"

I shook my head. "Adams, that was a dangerous game you played. The crown, once put on someone's head, cannot be taken off unless they themselves wish to take it off. Don't you think you're being a little too carefree with it?"

Adams shrugged hesitantly. "I guess, but you can take the crown off if they die, right? Meaning, if someone were to try and wear the crown, killing them would allow you to take it back."

I stared at him. This is strange. Adams hates killing other humans. He'd never suggest something like that normally. "Adams, it's unlike you to think of killing another human as an acceptable thing to do. The demons are our enemies, or have you forgotten?"

Adams waved off my criticism with a hand. "Of course, of course, but he was just a kid, and no harm came of it. I was very sure that he would do nothing bad, and as you can see, it paid off in dividends! If I had thought there was even a 1% chance of a betrayal, do you think I would have given him the crown?"

I paused as I considered my answer. "No... I suppose not but..."

I looked back at the crown that Adams was wearing. Does the crown change a person's personality? I've started changing as a person since I entered this labyrinth. Maybe it was the horrors I faced, maybe the crown changed me, maybe Blaarjiim and Hoarhiim did, maybe it was any one of a hundred factors. I speak more formally now, I walk with more reverence and confidence... I'm definitely different. But I'm also thirty now, and was in my teens when I entered. Could this be the result of a simple maturing, or something *else*.

I stared at the crown on Adams head. "I think I should like to hold onto the crown for a while."

Adams smile faded. "Slayer... you don't think... I would intentionally betray you?"

I squirmed inside. This was getting uncomfortable. What if he said no? "Ah, it's not that. I simply need help mentally nowadays. You know, I'm very scatterbrained as of late."

Adams slowly nodded as he looked into my eyes. "I... see. Very well then."

Reaching up, he placed both hands on the crown, slowly and hesitantly lifting it off. Before handing it to me, he seemed to gaze at it with sorrow in his eyes. Just as quickly as the emotion was there, it vanished as he handed it to me.

"As you wish. I care not." He smiled and chuckled, though it seemed uncomfortable to me, as his eyes darted away. "It's a small thing anyway."

"Yes..." I said, as I placed the crown on my head. As usual, the rush of mental brilliance streamed into my head all of a sudden, and the fog I had mentally felt as of late floated away, and suddenly I could breathe again normally.

And then, I realized something startling, thanks to the abilities of the crown.

Adams was lying about something.

Part 119:

I stared at the ground as I walked. I'm in the labyrinth now, all by myself for once... just like in the old days.

I've lived with my fellow humans now for 10 years. I'm beginning to wonder if I'm doing the right thing. I locked myself in that Cryopod to escape the hell of human activity, constant expectations, backstabbing, betrayal, and even just the general mundane parts of everyday life.

Yet here I am, once again, now I'm not just living among my fellow humans, I'm co-ruling them. Why did I decide to do this?

I gaze down at the three rings on my fingers. *Gabriel. Raphael. Michael.* My infinite vision sees them as three glowing rings of incredible concentrated spiritual power.

I chose to try and save my species, because that may be what the archangels wanted me to do. Truth be told, I don't want to lead people of my species, I just want to know they they *exist* and that they aren't being slaughtered and exterminated.

Looking from the rings to my body, I gaze in awe as I realize just how much I've grown. All these years of fighting, and thanks to my battle with Amelia teaching me a lesson, all those years without cheating by constantly enhancing my abilities with wordsmithing. I am massive. Standing exactly seven feet tall, with a body made of iron and forged with spiritual hammers and a thousand battles, even if I were just a normal human, I wouldn't want to mess with myself. My blonde hair is long and mostly unkempt, but I do bathe daily when I'm in Hero City... To be honest, I remind myself of images I've seen of mythological gods, like Thor and Zeus.

I've changed, in more ways than one. The tallest mountain started as a stone, and in the same way, I once was weak but now I've grown.

But I feel the same. I don't actually feel any physically different than I did all those years ago, when I entered this hell. But I need to change in another way. I need to stop being reactive, and become proactive. I've grown to rely on others, especially Adams, too much.

And... there's something else. I remember what Hoarhiim said to me, years ago, moments before he died. I can choose not to accept the name the labyrinth gives me. Why am I Slayer? Why have I accepted that? That name is not one befitting a man such as I. It's a name of darkness, given to me by this accursed labyrinth. It's a name that screams 'bloodthirsty killer'.

I don't want to be a voice for the darkness. I want to be a warrior of the light. I want the name that Gabriel honored me with.

I want to be *Hero* once again.

" *Hero*. " I say, pouring my energy into the word-spell. I'm not sure if this will actually do anything, and it doesn't seem to. Maybe nothing happened.

I pause and sigh. I'm getting all worked up over nothing.

As I walk down the corridors of the labyrinth, I begin to sense something up ahead, in the distance. There are many routes on this particular path which curves and loops, some sprouting off to the right, some off to the left.

But in the distance, I sense an aura of spiritual energy. It's weak, very weak, and yet very pure. This is not an energy I've sensed before. Most energy is dark, and twisted, I would classify that which I've sensed before as *demonic*.

This however, is a pure white energy. In fact, the only thing I can reference that is similar is Hoarhiim. But his wasn't pure white so much as it was just *bright*. This energy... it must belong to something very important.

As I approach it, the energy appears to come from an open doorway on the right side of the tunnel. Peering cautiously inside the room by craning my neck around the corner, I see a shocking sight!

Chained to the wall, there is an *angel* there. She appears to be completely affixed to it, with other various sets of chains covered in blood and other body matter littered around the room. This appears to be some sort of prison cell. But then, why is the door wide open.

I speak quietly, almost in a whisper. "My- my lady? Are you an... angel?"

Her head is slumped forwards and her entire body, arms and legs, are spread out and chained painfully tight to the wall, as she's suspended from the ground and hanging off by an inch or two. Her wings are also chained to the wall, as if whoever put her here wanted to take no chance of her wriggling even slightly.

Her head slumped forward, I almost can't tell if she's dead or not. I cautiously enter the room, careful to step around the puddles of... *body matter* all over the ground. There's no smell, perhaps because the pieces and bits are so old they've lost all their odors.

As I approach her suspended body, I hear a sound of grinding.

The door slams down behind me.

Part 120: Angel

I whip around and glance behind me. A massive steel door has slammed shut. If I had normal vision, the room would be pitch black aside from the dull light escaping the angel's body. Luckily I'm not, and I still see the room as perfectly as ever.

After the door slams shut, nothing else seems to happen, I step back towards it, starting to reach my hand out. As I do, the angel speaks, her voice a raspy whisper. "...Don't..."

I halt and turn back to face her. I have no sense of color and I can't visually see her in a normal way, but I vaguely get the idea that her hair is pure white as is her garb and everything else about her. Come to think of it, I've been in this maze and never seen angels at all before, aside from Gabriel. To be honest, I had thought they were completely extinct.

I walked over to her and stood in front of her. "Here... let me get you down."

As I reach for one of the locks, she whispers again. "...Don't."

She clearly has trouble speaking, likely because of something resembling dehydration. I reach my hand forwards. "*Cup. Water.*"

A plain cup of water appears in my hand, and I offer it to her. Her eyes seem dead but she lifts her head and lets me give her some water. When she lifts her head, I note a collar that is squeezing her neck. *Jesus*. What the hell did she do to deserve this punishment?

After a few painful swallows, she coughs, the cough causing her a great deal of pain. Without thinking, I reached up and touch the collar. "*Release*"

The collar pops off, as if it had been held together with scotch tape. Her breathing noticeably improves and her chest loses its tightness.

"Kah... you... shouldn't have... done that... he will be back... soon..."

I stare up and down with my mental vision at the 16 or so chains and cuffs holding her up to the wall. "Why don't you want me to release you? Do you like being in this... position?"

She coughed again, but words seemed to be coming to her more easily now that she could breathe. "Nay... I just didn't want to see you end up... like the others did." She beckoned with a head bob towards the piles of... *debris*. "Many have tried to save me over the years. All have failed."

I paused, my unseeing eyes staring at her face. "Who are you? Why are you here?"

She rasped a soft, pained laugh. "Ah... who am I indeed? I'm the last angel. Or... so they say... I sense none of the others anymore... I've been here for what feels like an eternity... in this hell."

I nodded. "Well, whatever the risk, I'll get you down from there."

I quickly spoke multiple times in succession. " *Unlock. Unlock. Unlock.* " As I aimed my mind at each of the cuffs, she started to fall free and I caught her, carefully lowering her to the ground. Of course, I also cast " *Clean.* " to remove the bloody mess from the room. It sparkles like a hospital in no time.

Her body has atrophied. She has little to no ability to move anything, likely from being chained to the wall for *god only knows* how long. Her wings are tattered and bloodied, and her back is covered in old scars.

"What is your name?" I try the direct approach. She seems responsive enough.

"I've... forgotten... my name." Her eyes stare blankly at the ceiling from her resting place on the ground.

That is unfortunate. I can't just keep calling her 'angel' as it sounds disrespectful. "All right, then for now, I will call you Cassiel. How does that sound?"

She smiled a light smile. "Ha... so long since I've heard a joke. Cassiel was a man, you know? And an Archangel at that... I don't deserve the honor. I'm just one angel from the resurrection project. I'm not even... a true angel, you know?"

I mulled this over in my head. What does she mean? Aren't angels just... angels? I only know what I know from Sunday School as a child from before I came here to Hell, but... this is not the time for questions. "Don't worry about it, I'll call you Cassiel anyway. If you're really the last angel, that makes you the highest ranking angel in existence, you know?"

Cassiel giggled slightly. "Truly, a breath of fresh air. But... it matters not. We cannot escape this room. And soon, Gressil will return to torture me some more."

My blood suddenly ran cold. "G-Gressil? It... can't be."

She nodded imperceptibly. "Yes... he is a cruel and foul demon. He takes delight in torturing and defiling the bodies of his victims. I was lucky that he was ordered not to kill me, but soon it won't matter anyway. I am dying from lack of thought energy."

I stared at her with my unseeing eyes. What does she mean by this? Do angels require thought energy to live? "How do you get more thought energy?"

She stayed quiet for a minute before speaking. "Well... in the olden days, the King of Gods, Zeus, would dole out thought energy collected from those who prayed to him to the various angels under his command. But when he was finally killed, thought energy was no longer directed at him. You have to pray to a specific angel in order for them to receive it. You also

could just give it to them if you have enough, but it requires a vast amount to sustain an angel's life. At least the power of a thousand humans."

I nodded. "Ah! I see! So, like this then?" I clasped my hand into hers and willed energy to leave my body. I felt a colossal amount of energy leave, roughly 80% of all my body's power, as suddenly her aura brightened visibly in my vision.

Cassiel gasped as she jerked up. "B-by Zeus' name! How did you...?!"

I shrugged. "I'm a pretty powerful human, you know."

She paused, as her eyes, now filled with more spiritual energy, came into focus. "You are... a hero?"

I nodded.

"Then... how are you... in this hell?"

I shrugged again. "I came here in a cry- uh, well, it's a long story."

She stared at my face. "You are quite handsome. But... I have... I have seen a face that looks like yours before. Long ago..." Her voice drifted off as she looked away from me. Then she glanced down at my hand, which was still clasping hers. I pulled it away in embarrassment, but she grabbed it again.

"My lord! This is...! These are the three rings of the...?!"

She seemed stunned. I then realized that *of course* she would be, these are the three highest archangels written about in the bible. Naturally she'd be stunned to see a lowly human wearing them.

She rubbed one of the rings with her finger.... "Gabriel... it can't be... I thought he was dead, but his presence... how did you come to have these rings? Who are you?"

I stared down at my hand that she was holding. Who am I? Who am I, really? What do I even know of myself?

I looked back at her. "My name is Hero. Just plain old Hero."

Part 121:

The formalities and introductions over, I turned my attention to the door. It was a pretty solid looking door, but nothing amazing.

I started to get up and walk towards it, but Cassiel grabbed my shirt. "Wait, don't touch it. That door has a curse on it. If you touch it, you will instantly die. Gressil is the King of Death and Torture."

I nodded. "Thanks for the warning." Then I pulled my arm away from her grasp and walked in front of the door. Reaching out with my mind I spoke.

" *Purify.* "

The door suddenly SCREAMED in agony and I jumped back in fright, as an apparition of a demon leaped out of the door at me, dissipating in midair. Holy shit, that was close!

Cassiel seemed to be visibly unnerved. "I've... seen that thing... kill too many people. How did you kill it so easily?"

I pointed at my chest. "I'm a special being. I'm unlike any you've ever met before."

She lowered her gaze to the floor. "Well, that would certainly seem to be the case, wouldn't it?"

I decided not to elaborate. It's not that I don't trust her, but having just given her more than half of my spiritual power, I'm decidedly at a decent disadvantage right now. I'll have to see if she's dangerous as we go along.

I reached my hand out and she grabbed hold of it as I pulled her up. Her silk robes were still torn and ripped in various areas, and her body was matted down with blood, especially on her wings. I aimed my hand at her body again. " *Cleanse. Repair.* "

Instantly, she brightened up as the dried blood vanished and her robes magically sewed themselves back together. She marveled at how quickly it happened. "Goodness, you're a man of a thousand talents! You speak a word, and it happens! Color me impressed."

I nodded. "It's been this way since I arrived here. Let's go."

I placed my hand against the door as Cassiel stood behind me, staring with curiosity at what I was doing. I decided to show off, *just a little*. Hey, I'm just a guy, you know?

" *Eradicate.* "

The door blasted into a thousand pieces outwards towards the direction my hand faced, the shrapnel vanishing instantly in midair.

I involuntarily screamed and jumped back as I saw a horrifying sight.

A massive monster was on the other side of the door.

It was Gressil.

Gressil was a terrifying demon, when not in statue form. He was smaller than I remembered, though still very big and towering above me. He appeared to be 11 feet tall, his huge frame barely fitting in the hallway. The door I had destroyed was only big enough for me to fit through, but using my power, I had also blasted away much of the outer wall surrounding the door.

He had wings now. I don't recall those from when I first saw him, all those years ago. His eyes were pitch black, and his long straight beak was filled to the brim with hundreds of small sharp teeth. He clacked his four armlike appendages together as he looked at me.

" Well well well, look what stumbled into my little trap. A knight in shining armor and the helpless maiden he rescued. Looking for a reward, were you? Heh heh heh. "

I grimaced as I glanced back at Cassiel. "Stay close."

I turned to Gressil. "Long time no see, you fucking horrifying demon creature, you."

Gressil quietly laughed. **" I'm an evolved gargoyle, whose ancestors came from the dark drakes born from the ancient dragons. I'm not a demon, but you are a lowly simian creature. "**

He eyed me up and down, my discomfort rising to incredible levels.

" Been having a lot of fun with those abilities of yours, huh? I've heard of what you can do. You're a dangerous little rat... but only if I let you... SPEAK! " Suddenly his tail whipped out from behind him. I tried to dodge it, but the whip-like speed caught me off guard as it wrapped tightly around my neck. I struggled mightily to pull it off, but I found it difficult to even move.

Cassiel screamed in horror as she saw me choking to death. "Let him go, foul monster of the dark!"

Gressil chuckled under his breath again, a low rumbling noise that sounded like thunder in the distance. **" Gwuh huh huh... are you scared, my pretty little angel? You were fun to play around with. This one though, he will be my favorite new toy to torture. After I break his throat, he will have no way of fighting back. "**

Cassiel grabbed at the tail wrapped around my neck, her hands pulling and tugging as she tried to wrench it off. The constriction was beginning to be too much for me as I could feel my mind slipping...

Suddenly Cassiel's eyes brightened as a light, from deep within her body began to emerge. "Oh Gressil, I'm not your little toy anymore. I had forgotten, this man saved my life, and during that, he gave me a small gift. Why not have a TASTE!"

Her hands jerked into motion as her lips moved wordlessly, her body suddenly brightening to unbearable levels, as if staring directly at the sun for ten days straight.

Gressil recoiled in horror. " **Gah! You goddamned angel! A little thing like this won't-** "

While he was recoiled in pain, his tail loosened its grip, ever so slightly. I quickly slid my hands underneath, between my throat and his tail, and took a deep breath.

" **PUSH!!!** "

A blast of energy surged out of my body, sending Cassiel and Gressil flying in opposite directions, away from me. The blast started from my head this time as I had willed it to do so, which expanded his tail away from my neck just enough for me to jerk down and slip out from underneath it. In a flash, using my superhuman speed, I darted backwards and grabbed Cassiel before she could smash into the wall.

"Sorry about that."

She appeared visibly confused. "Yeah, sure, no problem?!"

I let go of her and dashed back out to the doorway. " **Barrier!** "

A strong shield of spiritual energy surrounded me. Even at 20% energy left (which had dropped a lot due to using such a powerful Push spell) I was still not an opponent to trifle with.

Gressil lifted up his massive frame as he glared at me. " **A lot of fight for a tiny little ape. But unfortunately, you cannot win, now. Just by seeing me a second time, you have been cursed to die. Only I can undo this curse, and once placed, you will die a painful death due to natural causes. It will happen within two days' time.** "

I nodded. "Awesome, thanks for the tip!" I think my complete apathy towards his words was slightly humiliating.

" **You... brat. Mocking me. I'll make you regret those words.** "

I shook my head. "Nope!"

I aimed my hand at my body. " **Uncurse!** "

Seeing as quite a lot of my remaining energy vanished, I deduced that it must have worked. Gressil confirmed it with his next words. " **What?! How did you-?!** "

I shrugged. "I'm a special kind of guy. Next time we see each other, I'll crush you into dust."

Gressil charged at me. " **IMPUDENT LITTLE-** "

Before he reached me, I targeted myself and Cassiel. " *Return!* "

And suddenly, we were back in my house in Hero City, appearing right in front of Phoebe.

She jumped back in fright as our sudden appearance happened, then quickly recovered her nerves. "A-ah, master Slayer! It's a pleasure to see that you have retur-"

Her voice halted as she saw the angelic woman beside me, and then suddenly appeared to have a tinge of ice to it.

"So. Who is *this*?"

Part 122:

Hercules smiled as he stood at the front of the battlefield. Demons no longer tried to attack him, they were simply too fearful of his power. Instead they ran around him, aiming for his troops. Every time Hercules tried to charge out and attack one, it would get yanked out of the way by an invisible force.

He aimed his gaze at the bottom of the mountain ahead. There was a large number of holes in that mountain where demons poured out from, and in front of the biggest one, there stood Satan the Defiler, a being of monstrous strength who had evolved far beyond the level of his fellow demons.

Satan glowered menacingly, as he quietly spoke orders to his oracles, all of whom were sending mental signals to the troops on the battlefield.

This was the third time Hercules and his men had fought the demonic hordes, and it was going as splendidly as ever. Thanks to his shared vision power, his troops could see the entire battlefield around them at once. And anything they might miss was covered by scouts on the hills behind him who also shared their vision with his men below.

Hercules grinned. All too easy. Still zero men lost, and thousands of demons being destroyed. Come to think of it, it was almost *too* easy. If humanity had always had the ability to fight equally with demons, then why had they and the combined might of the angels and gods not eradicated the scourge yet.

Hercules pondered these thoughts. As a man of strength, one would expect him to be a simple minded brute, but in fact he was a genius of unparalleled wisdom. As a half-human half-god, he empathized with both races. He wanted no humans to perish under the armies of Satan, and also did not want angels to die either.

As he humored these thoughts, he heard a scream from one of his warriors! A scyther, the second weakest of all demons, had somehow scored a hit, the bladed mandibles gashing straight into his soldiers' heart.

Hercules leaped towards his warrior, arriving in the blink of an eye, and tearing the scyther out with a single hand, ripping its head off with the other. He quickly began to cast a healing spell, but it was already too late, the man's body slumped in his arms, dead.

Just as Hercules was trying to fathom what just happened, there was another scream, and another! Two more men were hit by hydras! Their venom was useless against the platemail he had invented, but on the skin, it almost always resulted in instant death. With his troops' shared

vision, they should be easily able to raise their shield to deflect the deadly spit, but this time, they did not.

And then he saw it actually happen in real time. One of his men swung an axe down towards a charging dark-walker, but just as it was about to hit, the axe jerked to the side in midair and missed completely. The darkwalker pulled a knife out of its shadow, stabbed his soldier in the eye and the man let loose a scream of pure agony, and then he slumped over, dead.

Hercules gasped when he saw this. What in the name of gods was going on?! Was this a new manipulation spell used by the foul demons?!

He jerked his head back and forth across the battlefield, but saw no traces of magic lines indicating that someone was sending spells at his men.

Then, could it be... sabotage?!

He jerked his head back, looking behind his men. As he did, he spotted the massive form of Gabriel over the horizon. Normally, Gabriel would be charging up his newest spell that incinerated the demons... but he did not this time. He was simply watching.

He watched the humans die.

* * *

Satan stared in disbelief. Before, he had not killed even a single one of these new soldiers, now they were falling like wheat to the scythe. What was happening out there?

He jerked back to his top general. "Barbatos, status report."

The demon looked around with his special sensing ability. "Hm. Something appears to be aiding us in our battle, some unknown force. Whatever it is, it keeps interrupting the otherwise impenetrable battle formation of those humans, giving our forces openings to attack."

Barbatos stared intently at the demonic forces that were suddenly rallying under the taste of blood and going into a frenzy, attacking the humans from all angles. "Ho ho ho, what have we here? I may be mistaken, but I think that human commander is about to call a retreat."

Satan stared evenly ahead. Fascinating. Who would be interfering and helping the demons, other than perhaps a different demon? Surely, the humans were not simply tired, they showed plenty of energy left. They were making bald-faced mistakes, something he had not seen them do before. Very unlike those he had called mortal enemies.

And, just as he was thinking of issuing another order, he saw Hercules reach under his shirt and pull out a massive horn, which he blew on. The loud, deep sound carried over the entire battlefield.

The sound of retreat.

Satan grinned evilly. "Well well well, looks like our enemies have a traitor amongst them."

Barbatos quietly let his mouth drop an unguarded hint of a smile. "We may have to make use of this for our own advantage."

Satan laughed quietly to himself. " *May* have to? We *will* make use of this."

Part 123: Unbridled Rage

" FATHER!! "

A voice boomed under Mount Olympus, as Hercules smashed a door out of his way with a fist, the door barely staying attached to its hinges, flying open and impacting the wall like the sound of a mountain collapsing reverberated throughout the deep.

"We have been BETRAYED!" Hercules stormed up to the altar in front of his father's throne, bowing quickly before standing up straight again. "This is incredible! My forces were wiping out the demons, and Gabriel... he was making my men miss their attacks, jerking their hands out of the way, he made my men die!"

Hercules breathed rapidly as his anger flared through his nostrils. Zeus opened his eyes as he ceased his meditation. "My son, surely you jest. Why should the highest gods allow one winning a war so effectively as you, with zero casualties, do something to prevent your efforts? What reward would they stand to gain?"

Hercules breathed hard as his mind raced. "Jealousy! They are jealous that a lowly demigod would be able to win where they could not before!"

Zeus nodded. "Yes, hm, I can see how that might be the case." He gripped his hands tightly as a bolt of thunder started forming, something that always happened when he started getting angry. "But it wouldn't explain sabotage. Think carefully, what else do you know?"

Zeus was doing what he usually did, soothing others when they annoyed him. However, Zeus himself had a very volatile temper for those that had offended him. He was a proud and haughty god, one who only did something if it was worth doing.

Hercules slowed his breathing as he let his rage somewhat subside. His mind still raced a thousand miles a minute, but his visible anger decreased noticeably. "Hmm... father... I have heard rumors, regarding you. I have heard that the other gods think of you as an angry child who hides in the deep. Perhaps, by bringing me down, they intend to bring shame to you and lower your position among the members of the Ten Highest?"

Zeus' eyes flared. "Oh? So they intend to betray the both of us? What fools. While they drink and celebrate, I have been down here, increasing my powers from the very heat that forged this Earth. The Core has given me powers in secret, powers that will give me my deserved position among the gods. I will topple that haughty, arrogant fool who calls himself my father, and your grandfather. And you, my son, will finally receive what you have always deserved."

Hercules nodded, his anger finally having washed away. "Worry not, father, I will find proof of this treason, even if I have to wring it from the throat of every god and angel I encounter."

Hercules pounded his chest with his right arm as he quickly bowed and made his way out.

Zeus stared at his son as he left. *That boy is a mighty son, but I must be careful, lest he overtake me someday, as I soon will my own father.*

Zeus quietly laughed to himself, as he sat in the darkness, alone with just his thoughts that he had obsessed with for an eon.

* * *

Satan and his demons stared at the map laid out in front of them on the Great Table. It showed the entirety of the known world in the immediate 400 mile surrounding area, with a single spot marked with a big red circle.

"You're certain of this?" Satan rubbed his chin as he looked around the location of the circle.

Barbatos bobbed his head. "Three of our best scouting patrols confirmed it. A darkwalker made it right up to the front before leaving, she was not seen either as far as we know."

Satan chuckled. "Of course she wasn't, the angels are too used to the light to notice something skulking in the dark. So is it guarded?"

Diablo nodded as he walked around. "In a way, it is. Angels and gods enter and exit constantly. There are also two cherubs standing guard inside the doorway, though the darkwalker was unable to confirm the existence of more."

The map seemed to draw Satan's gaze towards the big red circle. A tempting target. But Satan was no fool, he was the brilliant leader of the demons. "We know their hiding place now. Mount Sinai. We don't know what is inside it, but one can only presume the angels must live inside the bowels of the Earth somehow."

A cackling broke out as a few of the generals in the room found amusement in the idea of these high and mighty beings that they had feared for so long were nothing but tunnel rats.

Even Barbatos was not immune to the humorous thought. "Heh heh, dark lord Satan, you know what this means, right? We're fighting winged mole rats!"

Every demon in the room, Satan included, burst into laughter. "The fools sabotage themselves constantly, and they act high and mighty, but in the end they're just tunnel vermin playing god! We will tear their wings off and bury them in the dirt whence they came! Bahahaha!!" Satan roared with laughter as he imagined the face Gabriel would make once they had put him in a human coffin to spend the rest of eternity decomposing in.

The laughter died down after a few minutes as the realization of what they had to do sank in.

"If we want to defeat the humans, the gods, and the angels, we must wait, patiently. We will lose more demons, but when the time is right, we will strike them where it hurts most."

The generals of the room wiped away the tears of laughter and nodded approvingly at Satan's words.

We will wait.

Part 124: Nerves

Cassiel and I slowly walked through the streets of Hero City. Having finally explained the situation to Phoebe, she *harumphed* and left the house in a tizzy. Does... she like me?! I mean, she's at least a few million years older than me, (as is Cassiel, now that I think about it) but she would appear physically to be 20 years older than me. She's more like my mother than... yeah.

And Cassiel? She appears to be permanently youthful, having apparently died at the tender young age of twenty-five in a horrific car crash. She wouldn't go into details, but I did know that before she died, she was a girl who went to church all the time and prayed a lot. I guess that is why she became an angel?

But something else is bothering me. Cassiel said she wasn't a 'true' angel. What does that mean anyway? What's the difference? And if she's not a true angel, does that mean she doesn't count, I can't say I now know of four (Five? Was Hoarhiim an angel originally? I dunno!), I only still know the three archangels in my rings.

Where did all the angels go?

Cassiel won't say. She clearly knows though. Based on what I've gleaned from hints in the conversations, and what the Crown has allowed my brain to extrapolate, something happened that killed off every angel in existence. I don't know the when, the where, the why, or the how, but I know it *did happen*. It's just another mystery of this Hell.

As for Cassiel, I can't truly determine how she looks. I have a vague mental image of her and Phoebe's body lines, but it's not like back when I could see. I can see colors based on spiritual energy, I can sense approximate physical ages, I can even detect a person's current health by how they walk, and many other such things, but it's not the same. I do not have the ability to see things properly.

...As Cassiel and I walked, I noticed something odd. She was *trembling*, especially when anyone drew too close to her. She was being looked at with a wide variety of emotions, as people could clearly see she was not a normal human, and anyone with half a brainstem could deduce she was an angel. Finally, to top it off, she was walking with the Slayer (They still call me that, *ugh*), which made her stand out even more, as I was clearly no clone.

And I think I know why she is trembling. She's not necessarily shy, but she's been locked up and all alone for millennia, eons even. I think I made a mistake.

I reached over and placed my hands on her shoulder. Since she wasn't expecting that, and she wasn't looking at me at that moment, she jerked back involuntarily, and quickly leaned back

when she realized it was just me.

"Oh, Hero. I'm s-sorry, I didn't mean to jump like that..." She was very nervous, her voice was shaking like a tree in the wind.

"Cassiel, are you a little scared with all these people around? I know it must be hard, coming out around so many of them all at once..."

Cassiel quickly shook her head *way* too enthusiastically. She was clearly trying to assuage my concerns and not make me feel guilty. "N-no! I'm just, ah, shaking in *excitement*! I've never been in such a big city before with, uh, so many people!"

Her stuttering and stammering made it pretty clear she was lying, but I just rolled with it. If she doesn't want to go home or hide in a corner, I'm not going to be a knight in shining armor. "Yes, I see what you mean. It's very exciting the first time, huh?"

She threw her head up and down enthusiastically in the most endearing form of a nervous nod I've ever seen. It took all my power to contain my laughter from bursting out!

* * *

We arrived in the castle after going for our walk. She visibly relaxed once we were in the far less crowded corridors where only a few maids and noblemen walked past, here and there.

As we walked, something interesting happened. *I became the one who was nervous*. It's only been a few days since I last spoke with Adams, taking the crown from him. As Cassiel grew calmer and calmer, I grew more and more nervous.

How should I act towards him? I was never really good with social problems when I was young, before I entered this place. I always avoided my problems or stopped talking to the people bothering me. But I don't have that luxury now. I'm effectively the most powerful human in existence, a being known formerly as *Hero*. I cannot sit by the sidelines and passively let others do what they want. I put Adams in charge, and if I need to... I could take him down.

Or... can I? He's integral to the survival of the human race at this point. So what if he made a mistake? I judged him too harshly for it. I know he wouldn't do it again. Giving the crown to someone else will never be a thing he does again. Yes, that's it! I've been too mean towards him. The man has done so much for humanity, while I was lazy and just had fun blowing things up with my powers, being worshiped as a god.

I need to go in there and apologize to him. He doesn't do everything he does, selflessly, every single day with no rest, and deserve to be treated the way I treat him. I'm just plain awful.

As we walked, I sensed Cassiel turning towards me. "Hero? Are you quite all right? You haven't said a word for almost ten minutes, and you seem very nervous."

I nodded quickly. "Yes, thank you Cassiel. I am fine! Was just... thinking about something important I have to do!"

Cassiel slowly turned away, smiling. "Well then, as long as you say so, I suppose."

As we walked, a familiar person walked in front of me. One I hadn't seen in months.

"Beelzebub! You're still here!"

The demon turned towards me and a look of disgust crossed over his face. " *You*. "

Fantastic. Glad to see he's in a good mood, as always. "How are you doing, old buddy old puppet pal?"

"I'm doing just *amazing*, as you know. I just *love* working for humans, doing their dirty deeds."

I nodded enthusiastically. "Mhm! You're always a sight for sore eyes! I'll never forget the look on your face when I killed you!"

Beelzebub rolled his eyes dramatically, and then he paused before continuing on. "Hmm? An angel? It can't be. I thought we... exterminated your kind."

I mentally looked back at Cassiel. She was shaking again, this time in outright *terror* as no words could escape her mouth. Of course, she fears demons greatly. Damn! I was careless. I should have thought of what this meant to her.

I wrapped my right arm around her shoulders and turned to Beelzebub. "Alright pal, this was a good talk, but we'll be heading off now. See ya."

Leaving Beelzebub staring after us quizzically, I quickly hurried off with Cassiel and we continued on the path towards the War Room.

"Cassiel, are you doing okay?" She was still shaking badly, whatever the hell the demons had done to her, it left a deep mental wound. One she'd likely never recover from.

Cassiel shook her head, finally admitting that she wasn't okay. We came to a stop and I let her sit in a comfortable looking chair as she wiped tears out of her eyes.

"I... can't believe you're friends with... with... one of th-those monsters..." Cassiel shook as she tried to hold back tears, but the effort was futile as they slowly crawled out of her eyes and down her skin.

I knelt down lower than her and looked up at her. It was a mostly pointless gesture, due to my blindness, but I think it made her feel better. "No, Cassiel, we're not exactly friends. I killed him many years ago, and revived his corpse as my puppet. I've done it to many other demons

besides him. I do this to mock him forever, and to make him pay for how his kind has treated humans... and the angels."

Cassie slowly managed to stop crying as she wiped away her tears, and then her embarrassment overcame her as she realized she hadn't been strong enough to hold in her trauma in front of me.

I leaned in and hugged her tightly, as she did me. After a few seconds we got up and walked again, as she broke the silence. "Thank you, Hero. You are... truly a kind man."

I smiled. "It's my pleasure, Cassiel. What good is a man if he's not a shoulder for a woman to cry on when she needs it?"

Cassiel beamed at me. "If only we had met before I died... I might have fallen for you."

I felt myself blushing at the thought as did she, and we walked the rest of the way in silence.

* * *

We arrived in the war room, as Adams and many of his top generals were huddled around the war table, muttering and whispering to one another. When the two of us entered the room, they stopped speaking and quickly stood up straight.

Adams was the first to open up. "Slayer! Good to s-see you again! I didn't expect you would be back so soon!"

As he spoke, my mental vision watched as another man sneaked out the back of the room, holding onto some form of rolled up parchment. What was going on here?

I decided to ignore it. "Yes, there was a major complication in the labyrinth and I had to make a rapid return."

The men in the room suddenly seemed to notice the angel next to me, their faces showing various expressions, mostly shock and admiration... some showed other emotions, such as silent lust.

Adams bopped his head a bit. "Yes, yes... I see. We were just discussing some boring things regarding the behind the scenes war effort."

Adams indicated that everyone should sit down, and we did. Many men, I noticed, could not, would not, or simply had not taken their eyes off Cassiel. It seemed to unnerve her, but I could feel a different emotion boiling up inside me. *Jealousy*.

We spoke about various day to day dealings and such for a few minutes, and Adams then turned to me. "Ah yes, would you mind if I borrowed the Crown for a few hours? I need to work

on some designs for a new weapon and it greatly improves my drawing speed and thought process."

This was it. I knew it was coming. Adams loved wearing the crown, I know he did. I felt many impulses in my body screaming not to let him have it this time, but in front of all these generals, many of whom I respected, I felt I had no choice.

Taking off the crown, I leaned over the table and handed it to Adams. He smiled as he took it. "Excellent! I'm glad we're past the, um, issue we had earlier."

I nodded as I leaned back in my chair. Suddenly, something smashed into the back of my head and I fell forwards, my body still weak from the spiritual power loss from earlier.

As I fell, I heard Adams speak again. "Unfortunately, it's time to take matters into the hands of humanity. Thank you for your services, Hope."

As I drifted off into a sleeping abyss, I heard many things. Cassiels voice was screaming something, the generals in the room were shouting, but another voice stood out, like a black mark on a white paper.

It was my *own voice* speaking, but it didn't come from me.

"It was my pleasure, Adams. I will take over now."

Sleep came to me then.

Part 125: Quiet

Ugh... hell... fuck... everything hurts...

I wake up in a daze. My head is pounding, and I feel lethargic. I can't seem to move my body in the slightest.

As I awaken, I notice something terrifying. *All of my 360 degree spatial vision is gone.* I can't see anything at all. I can only hear things. And... all I hear is breathing, creepy breathing from multiple people in the same room as me.

I'm beginning to feel a bit spooked as my eyes open and I realize that not only are my feet tied together, and my hands are bound behind my back... I'm suspended from the ceiling?!

I appear to be in some form of a straitjacket. It's hard to tell, but something is constricting my entire body tightly.

As these thoughts race through my mind, I hear an echoing *boom* in the distance. Footsteps. Two or three sets, I think, though it's hard to tell.

The footsteps draw nearer, and a door creaks open, the sound making an ominous echoing sound, like I'm in some underground room. Prison?! No, this must be a practical joke, there's no way-

"Slayer, so good to see you awake. Sorry about, eh, stringing you up like a pig for the slaughter. It was necessary." Captain Adams was speaking. I'd recognize his voice anywhere. The voice of a close friend, a comrade, a trusted agent... *a betrayer.*

I opened my mouth to speak, and nothing came out. No words at all. I felt my mouth making movements, and I could push air up my throat, but nothing came out. And when I opened my mouth, I felt horribly nauseous, likely because I am strung upside-down.

Another voice speaks. *My voice, again.* But this voice comes from another person that entered with Adams.

"My apologies *Slayer*, but we had to do this. You're a failure in more ways than one, and your doubting the King will be the undoing of the human race. I'll be taking over as the new Slayer now." This was definitely my voice. A sentient clone?! One with intelligence and a personality?! Had Adams or someone else figured out a way to make one of my clones into a normalized puppet in the same way as Beelzebub?!

The clone continued speaking. "Allow me to explain the current situation to you. You're currently suspended by your legs about two feet from the floor. I cast Silence on you, so you're

unable to speak. I know of your infinite 'storage' ability and as one of the last clones you created, I have all your recent memories, so I'm perfectly aware of the artifacts you're hiding. However, without the ability to speak, you cannot summon any of them. In fact, without the ability to speak, and with me dispelling all your abilities and buffs, you're essentially helpless, even if we weren't to string you up like this."

I could feel tears forming as I wordlessly opened my mouth to protest and beg Adams not to make a horrible mistake. Why would he do this to me?! HOW?! I gave the clones the orders to obey me above all others, *then* Adams, then their commanding officers! Why would-

...Ah. That explains it. If just one clone somehow, in some way, gained sentience, and I was away, Adams could have ordered the clone to ignore orders from everyone but himself. Then he could have ordered the clone to knock me out. That would explain why the clone didn't appear anywhere in my spatial vision. Perhaps the clone was shielding his presence with a word spell.

Adams spoke again. "Sorry about putting you in this position, old friend. If you had just kept things the way they were, you would have been fine. But your hesitation and greed could cost humanity the war. Hope will be taking over for you in all your daily functions, so even the people un-involved with this plot won't notice that you're missing. As for why we didn't just kill you? Well, we're not sure if killing you will dispel all of your clones. If that happened, chaos would come and thanks to our angering of the demons, we'd surely be overrun."

He sighed, a long, hard, drawn out breath. "I wish... it didn't have to end up this way. We will go on living just fine without you. But you... I always considered you a friend. Even now, I still do. But you're simply in the way now, you're an impediment to the future of humanity as you are now. My deepest apologies."

As they turned to leave the room, Adams turned to look at me. "Oh yes, you've been out of it for a couple days. I just had Hope declare me the King of the humans. Something *you* never had the will to make happen. Always calling me 'captain'. What an insult. After all my leadership and abilities I've shown, you always treated me like a sideshow. I'm so... tired of this. Farewell, Slayer."

And with that, they left. I was alone now, with what were apparently guards, in my prison cell.

Fuck.

Part 126: Suspended

I hang here, an empty shell of a man.

I can feel that my spiritual and thought energy has returned. Having been hanging here for a couple days, it's all there. But... I have no ability to use it.

I'd have sighed if I could make any noise.

I've deduced by the complete and total silence in the room that the guards around me are either very antisocial assholes, or they're clones. Just... wordlessly staring at the hanging body of the one that gave them life. Yeah, they're just assholes anyway.

I blankly stared at the total darkness around me. I'm tired of all the shit I keep having to put up with. I slave, day in and day out, to help humanity. I give my spiritual and mental energy, often having to sleep for days at a time, just to summon clones to help these people, and they shit all over me.

To hell with humans. I'm so tired of their pretentious way of talking. I'm so tired of the fake respect and humble bowing. If this is the way they really feel about me, just a TOOL to be used, it's no wonder the demons want to torture and enslave all humans. At least the demons have respect for one another.

...Yeah. Maybe I've been looking at it wrong all this time. Maybe the demons aren't the bad guys here. Sure, they look like monstrosities, they hunt down and kill all humans, they murdered the entire angelic race, and they're cocky, smug dipshits half the time... but at least they don't kill one another. They have disputes, but they live their lives in relative harmony.

Are humans the real monsters? Even before I came here in this Cryopod, my own species seemed to alienate me. I was mocked as a kid, called names, laughed at, made fun of, and it didn't get much better as I got older. I held down a couple jobs, but my coworkers always made fun of me behind my back. My family treated me as a loser because I was always reading or playing games and flipping through comics.

The reason I got in that cryopod... I think I just wanted to end it all. Maybe I was feeling suicidal and didn't care what happened to me. Those signups for the test program at CryoTek... they were too tempting. Freeze yourself to enter into the future, for free. Sure, it had a chance of going horribly wrong, but I always saw news reports about their successes freezing Henry the Pig for a year and unfreezing him. The technology worked.

I saw it all happen, and I wanted to be a part of something, *anything* was better than my boring monotonous life doing what bosses told me to do, living in a small apartment with a menial life that was guaranteed to end up with me dying old and alone someday.

Once again... I'm feeling it all return. The emotions and feelings I bottled up for 10+ years. I was never prepared for anything, I've been just winging it since I arrived here.

But... no more. If I can just escape this fucking prison cell, I will shit holy fire upon Adams for his betrayal. I will destroy my clone, I will rescue Cassiel, I will leave this place, and I will stake out my own life in this labyrinth, free of other humans.

But... how? How the hell can I escape this situation? It'd be convenient if Hoarhiim would suddenly reawaken right now. That's not going to happen though. Cassiel is the only one who might be able to help me, but I don't know where she is. I'm not sure if Phoebe is on my side or not, or if she even knows what's going on.

* * *

Crap! That clone is going to pretend to be me, Phoebe probably won't even know I'm gone! And to top it off, even if she figures it out, I'm still stuck here.

THINK! What can I do to escape this situation?! There has to be something! I'm a goddamned Hero! I have the ability to make fantasy into reality with just a single word!!

* * *

Hah... it's no use. I can't think of a thing.

Wait.

My hands are bound inside the straitjacket, but... I feel something... no. It can't be. Is Adams a fool? Is my clone? They didn't actually... hahaha...

I'm still wearing the three rings of the Archangels, I'll pull one of them off and put it back on, maybe that will activate it and give me something to work with. Anything is better than nothing, right?

As I slip the ring off, and slip it back on, a familiar sensation falls over my body. It's called *nothing happens*.

Son of a bitch.

I heave my chest in and out in a silent form of a sigh. I really am doomed, aren't I?

But... these rings... I've worn them for *ten* years. They can't seriously be valueless, can they? No. These are the three mightiest archangels. They must be able to aid me.

I focus my mind as a single name appears. *Raphael. I need your wisdom. I need your guidance. Please, open up to me. Speak to me... Raphael...*

Raphael...

Raphael!

RAPHAEL!!!

The darkness begins to swirl around me, as I appear around a familiar campfire once again, in a small clearing I've seen before.

An old man sits across from me, warming his hands by the fire.

"Oh? So you've returned to keep me company?"

Part 127:

I watered the plants as I did my usual daily busywork, waiting for him to get home.

Having just bought some food from the local market, I found myself wondering, as I had for the last week or so, *what is going on?*

First, he comes home with this... this... sexy young little angel girl... He just POOFS into the kitchen right next to me, scaring the heavens out of me, brushes it off, goes on a walk with her, and then he leaves for a couple days.

What the heck is going on these days? He's always so busy, and I find it unnerving to have so many of his mindless, speechless clones walking all over the city. They're not nearly as good at conversation as he is, to put it bluntly. Ah, actually, they don't speak at all unless it's to cast spells.

Ah... I still remember the first time I saw him. It was almost 11 years ago. I had just awakened from Bahamut's spell, as did the rest of the people in this city. Having lived for a short eternity as a monster that did whatever Bahamut wished, I had grown accustomed to being ordered around like a pawn on a chessboard.

But then this wonderful young man, or rather, I suppose he was just a boy of twenty at the time... he came and rescued all of us, defeating our captor! And despite his incredible genius, despite his powers, despite his heroism and the adoration given him by the people... he never let it go to his head.

He's a humble man, even now. He never gets full of himself. He never insults anyone or depreciates them. Not even me, a household slave who had been imprisoned by a ruthless monster, was spared his kindness. He always treated me with respect, never ordering me around, never talking down to me as if I were worthless. He simply... respected me.

And then he got in that awful accident. I found myself... drawn to him. He kept trying to set me up with others... but I didn't want to do that. I don't like Adams. Not just in a non-romantic manner, I just don't trust him. He's too nice. He's too good to be true. He's always bothered me. After ten years of faithful devotion to the man who saved our people, you'd think I'd have come to respect Adams but... I can't. I just can't.

Adams was proclaimed king recently, and the man that I... love... he has not returned yet, not for the last couple days. But seeing that angel next to him... I see now. He's an attractive, strong, powerful man. I can't simply stand by and watch. I can't just let him be taken away by

another woman. Even if he doesn't want me anymore... I have to tell him. I have to make this right.

I have to take a chance. I can't be silent anymore.

As these thoughts cross my mind, I see something that makes my heart jump. It's him! Him and Adams... ugh. They're walking down the path towards his cottage. Perfect, I'll go over there and say hello, make some food, and when Adams leaves, I'll just... I'll do it! I'll finally do it! Even if he rejects me, you can't make an omelet without breaking some eggs!

I walk over to the cottage a few minutes after he enters. Can't rush in too quickly, it could make things awkward.

As I enter, Adams greets me. "Oh, hello Phoebe! Great to see you again! We haven't talked much, have we, of late?"

I shake my head. "Ah, no, I do apologize for that, King Adams. Congratulations on your coronation! You deserve it!"

Adams nodded as he closed his eyes and smiled. Despite my thoughts, he really is a humble man. He will make a fine, if flawed king.

Adams turns away from me and speaks to the man I love. "Ah well, in any case, keep me up to date. Have a good day, Slayer."

As he starts to walk away, a question takes shape in my mind and forms on my lips. "Hmm? Weren't you calling yourself Hero now?"

Adams freezes just before he reaches for the door, and looks at Hero. "Oh. Hm, yes. Now that I think about it, you did change your name, didn't you. How *careless of me*."

Part 128:

Once again, I found myself staring into the flickering firelight. Raphael stared into it too, neither of us saying anything at first.

I broke the silence. "I was betrayed."

Raphael raised an eyebrow. "All good men are, eventually. The only people who are never betrayed are those not worth betraying in the first place."

I closed my eyes as I warmed myself at the fire. "Raphael... you told me, when we last spoke, that you would be the one asking the questions when I next came. What did you mean by that?"

Raphael nodded slowly. "I have many questions I wish to ask of you, truth be told. But now you know the secret, you know you can visit me whenever you wish to, just as you can visit the other two."

I smiled slightly. "So will you answer my questions first? If you don't then I may die and be unable to answer your questions in the future."

Raphael frowned at me. "Careful now, you're starting to become smarter. That is logic that I hear you using."

"Haha, yes, I suppose it is." I chuckled wryly. "Raphael. How can I free myself from this mess? Must I wait for a savior?"

Raphael looked up from the fire at me as I opened my eyes and met his. "Surely you jest. You were given a divine title by my younger brother. *Hero*. Does a Hero do the rescuing, or is he one to be rescued?"

I shook my head. "You're right, of course. I have to be the Hero and rescue myself. Haaaah, it just seems impossible."

Raphael looked back down at the fire. "You misunderstand. I neither said it was good nor bad to do either one of those things. Perhaps you *should* be rescued. After all, a true Hero needs to rely on his companions, as well as himself."

I shook my head again. "No, it's wrong. I don't need to be rescued. I should do this myself. I got myself into this situation by trusting others too easily, I need to get myself out."

"Trusting in others is not a bad thing. Trusting too easily though, that is something that is remedied with experience. Even I was betrayed once. All of the angels were."

I jerked my head up. "What? You were betrayed?!"

Raphael gazed back down, into the fire, as he closed his eyes and a single tear slipped out. "I was betrayed. Betrayed by one I thought a friend. A friend I had known since as far back as I dared remember. He slipped a figurative knife into not just my back... but the back of everyone that I knew."

I could sense tears welling up as he spoke. Those wise old eyes... Compared to my friendship of ten years with Adams... surely his betrayal cut more deeply than anything I could possibly imagine.

"Raphael. Do you know? Do you know how I can escape this place?"

Raphael raised a feeble old hand up and wiped the tears from his eyes. "What if I were to tell you? What good would that do for me? Do you expect me to do you a favor for free?"

I paused. To be honest, I did. But... he's lost everything. I don't know what I could possibly do to...

I'll try the simple approach. "What do you want me to do for you? If it's within my power, I will do anything."

Raphael nodded and smiled, for the first time ever. It was a sweet smile, reminding me of a tender grandfather as he looked at the moving form of a baby grandchild.

"I was only jesting, young child. But... I want you to make me a promise."

I paused. A... promise? "Of course. What is it?"

Raphael heaved a small sigh. "I want you to promise me... you'll end this war. The whole war. Make peace with the demons. Not just the ones outside, but the ones inside your heart."

I closed my eyes again. Make peace? With... the demons?

"Why would you ask this of me?"

Raphael stared at me intently. "The demons won the war against the angels. They killed everyone I knew. But... we deserved it. Angels are not the arbiters of justice. We were a corrupt, immoral group. We... *deserved* to lose."

He stared again at the fire. "Demons, humans, angels. They only do what is in their own self-interest. I don't have all the answers. I'm not all knowing. I'm not truly the wisest, despite what they may say. But I do know this: The demons are not evil. They have many positive qualities, they do many good things for each other. They lack certain flaws that both angels and humans possess."

"And, if you promise me to make peace, you must promise me one other thing. Protect Cassiel. She is the very last living angel. Despite being a reborn human, and not a true angel...

she's the last remaining one of us. I beg you... protect her. I don't want... to see us... go extinct."

I nodded slowly, for the last time. "Tell me what I must do. I will do anything to fulfill your wishes."

"Good. I thank ye, Hero. Go now, and speak to Gabriel. Of my brothers, he is the one that will be able to help you escape."

I stood up, and bowed my head. "Thank you, Lord Raphael. I *will* escape. I *will* end this awful war. I will do what must be done."

Raphael stood up and walked over to me. Placing his hand on my shoulder, I once again felt a surge of magic enter my body. "Farewell, Hero King."

I came to, seconds later, still suspended in darkness.

Gabriel.

Part 129:

Hercules walked alongside his father, the great god, Zeus. As the god of thunder and lightning, he possessed explosive power, and a temper to match. He was in the top ten gods, but when it came to his actual abilities, he was feared and respected by all of them. He had known for a great many eras that this was the case, and had thus secluded himself for an incredibly long time.

But Zeus had not gotten weaker. In fact, he was stronger now than he ever had been before. Like his father and his mother before him, Zeus was a Titan. Unlike other Titans though, he possessed even more strength than one would expect, seeing as he had been capturing and devouring angels in secret. Their deaths were always attributed to demons, but truly it was Zeus. Their wings were the most important part, as those concentrated their spiritual powers and gave rise to many different abilities of his. The most important ability had been his evolution that allowed him to control the weather, notably thunder and lightning.

Zeus was truly a mighty god, and soon, he'd have the chance to prove it. He was a fearless god, bringing only his son with him. He had many angels in the Court of the Holy Gardens who aligned more with him than they did Kronos' way of ruling, and he knew a few of the lesser and greater Gods were on his side too.

He approached the Throne of his father and his high court. Zeus stretched his shoulders around a bit.

"Great Lord, Kronos! I have come today to ask questions of you!"

No god ever called Kronos "father" as he had sired many many children among the female titans of old. Zeus had fathered a number of children himself, but their numbers were eclipsed by Kronos thanks to his vast age advantage.

Kronos, who was meditating on his throne, stirred. "Hmm? Zeus? Ah yes, it has been a long time since you made an appearance here in my court. What brings you to these walls?"

Zeus grimaced. *Playing the buffoon, eh?* "Father, I have... heard from my own son, that there was... treachery.. on the battlefield. One of your angels caused a great battle, which would have been otherwise victorious, to go awry. He caused the death of many of my son's pawns. I want an explanation!"

Kronos stared down at the son standing before him. Zeus was, no doubt, one of his strongest children. Kronos feared none of his sons or daughters. Nevertheless, if he had to put up with their nonsense constantly, he'd never have time to rule.

"Zeus. Are you accusing someone in my court... of treachery?"

Zeus stared back evenly. "Yes." His glare met his father's emotionless, unblinking stare. The two of them seemed to shoot invisible sparks at each others eyes.

Kronos slowly rose from his seat to his full height. His son was an ant compared to him. Kronos stood dozens and dozens of feet taller than his child, even though he himself was minuscule compared to Gabriel.

"You know what this means, don't you? You either must provide evidence for your charges... or you must duel with the King."

Zeus sneered. A rigged court in favor of his father's pet angel, Gabriel? Never in a million years. *Kronos has eaten many of my brothers and sisters when they defied him, but I will not fall as they did.*

"A duel then! I will duel you for the right to the throne! When I have reached the throne, I will take it over for myself and right this grievous wrong!"

Kronos chuckled to himself slightly. *The young fool thinks he can defeat the one who slayed the two great Titans of old. Those two titans were a monumental terror to the cosmos. Compared to me, my son is an insect.*

"Very well, we will go to the Courtyard of Resentment and have our duel there."

Zeus nodded. "I have long waited for this day, *father.*"

Kronos glowered at his son. "That is *king* to you."

* * *

The three archangels were away on an important mission to the north. Zeus and his father, Kronos, stood apart from each other in the mighty and massive Ring of Dueling, almost three miles in diameter, at the Courtyards of Resentment. It was a ring covered in marble blocks, incomparably vast in size. More than enough room to settle a score between two Titans.

The archangel Uriel presided over this match, levitating above the arena. "The rules are simple. Defeat your opponent using any method possible. Whoever will be crowned king must be smarter, faster, and stronger than anyone else. Kronos has proven time and again that no angel or god can defeat him. Zeus, if you can defeat him, you will be crowned king and assumed the strongest. However, you will still periodically have to fight others who challenge your position. If you do not agree to these rules, you may leave now, and hang your head in disgrace for all eternity. Do you accept the terms?"

Zeus grimaced. *Listen to the bias in favor of my father.* "Yes! I will defeat you, as this has been a long time coming! Revenge for all my brothers and sisters!"

Kronos glowered at the tiny figure in front of him. "I have won thousands of duels across thousands of ages. Giving up and living in disgrace would be preferable to suicide, you know?"

Hercules watched from the sidelines, as thousands upon thousands of angels and gods seated themselves or flew to get a good vantage point.

The great god, Zeus, stared up at the mountainous figure of his father. "You think this will be easy, don't you, father?"

Kronos shook his head. "No, my son. *I know it will be.* "

Uriel grimaced as the two threw cliched threats and verbal insults at each other. *Just get this over with so I can go and take a nap.* "Very well, the contestants have agreed to this duel. The match shall begin in three... two... one... BATTLE!"

Part 130: Clash Of The Titans

Nobody had expected such a fantastic display of battle prowess as the one that occurred on that day. Hercules and the thousands of angelic and godly spectators stared with fascination at the battle that was to take place before them.

Zeus stood perfectly still when the battle started. Kronos laughed. "Letting me have the first attack, eh?" Kronos quickly raised up his foot and slammed it down, intending to stomp the child beneath him. The impact shook the grounds of Heaven and a few angels still walking to their seats tumbled down and lost their footing.

When he raised his foot again, Kronos saw that Zeus was not there anymore. "Looking for me, *father*?"

Zeus floated in midair behind Kronos, a big smirk on his face. *He's fast*. Kronos thought to himself.

Kronos jerked his right hand towards Zeus, but Zeus vanished again, appearing next to Kronos' left ear. "You'll have to be faster than that, *daddy*."

Kronos grew angry at the words of mockery, and suddenly jerked into motion. Jumping, running, grabbing, he chased his agile son all over the arena. Zeus appeared to not even move from one place to another, he simply vanished and reappeared.

The king of the gods paused after a few minutes. "Well well, looks like we've got a stalemate here. You're too fast for me to catch, but I'm too big and strong for you to hurt. What will you do then?"

Zeus laughed. "Hahaha, I can move instantly at the speed of light. It's the power I gained when I gained control over lightning and storms. But I'm not fast and weak, I'm fast and *strong*. That mistake will cost you dearly."

Suddenly he disappeared, reappearing next to Kronos ear again, with a mighty battlecry, he blasted the sound of thunder point blank into Kronos' auditory centers. Kronos bellowed as the sound blasted out his eardrum, his inner ear rupturing and blood pouring out of it. As he grabbed his ear in agony, Zeus appeared again, doing the same thing to his opposite ear, causing Kronos immense pain and to become completely deaf.

Kronos fell to his knees in bone shaking agony, as his eyes slammed shut from the pain overriding his mental faculties. When he finally regained the ability to open his eyes, he saw

Zeus floating mere inches from his face, preparing a big spell. The instant Kronos opened his eyes, Zeus activated it.

A fantastically bright twin bolt of lightning blasted out of Zeus' hands, lancing directly into his father's eyes. Kronos screamed, roared, and bellowed in agony as his eyes exploded into a bloody mess. He started swinging his right hand around wildly, trying desperately to slap Zeus out of midair, but he was unable to hit a thing.

Zeus floated above his father's kneeled body, a sense of sorrow passing over his face. "You were a dear leader to our people, pushing us through many dark times." He spoke to the man who could no longer hear. "I do not do this out of hatred. I do this because it is time to begin a new era. One without the influence of the demons. My own son and I will eradicate them, as you were unable to do. For the good of angels, gods, and our human cattle, we will lead this universe to a new age of peace and prosperity."

A single tear went down his cheek as he spoke. "I'm sorry, father. I love you, despite your flaws."

His hands whipped into a frenzy as he wordlessly began preparing a spell unlike any other in his lifetime. The otherwise serene, peaceful and bright sky over heaven, magically illuminated with no visible suns, became cloudy and dark, as a massive storm began brewing.

As his father raged and screamed, the cloud began emitting great sparks and loud booming thunder emanated from it, as Zeus prepared his ultimate spell.

He looked down on his father from on high. This would be the last time he saw him alive.

" Fulmen e Caelo! "

A blast of lightning shot down from the sky, the size of which nearly compared to Gabriel's own cosmos-class magic light wave. The bolt hit Kronos with such speed and force that he had no time to even scream in pain. His body ruptured internally as a wave of blood and liquefied internal organs erupted from all of his orifices. He instantly lost his footing, and fell down, his body smashing into the ground with the force of an asteroid traveling the speed of sound. Many later theorized that the bolt of lightning had such force that it slammed him into the ground at high speeds, though no tests were ever done to confirm it.

Zeus stared stonily at the massive corpse below him. His tears gone, he raised his fist in the sky.

The audience at first was completely quiet, but Hercules broke that silence. "HURRAH! My father is the decisive victor!"

The audience erupted in cheers. Such a fantastic and powerful god would surely lead them to crushing the demonic hordes!

As everyone cackled with glee and delight, one person remained silent. Uriel watched from on high. As one of the archangels, he had not expected that this would be the result. He had thought Kronos was unkillable. But now that Kronos was gone, he knew sweeping changes were coming, and the results would be anything but positive for his kind.

Part 131:

As I hung suspended from the ceiling, I concentrated, deep in my mind, and spoke his name.

Gabriel.

Again, the blackness around me melted away, as my eyes opened and I could see once again. Whiteness surrounded me as I began free-falling through the sky. Infinitely falling, falling for an eternity, it was a feeling that made me feel violently ill, but also small and insignificant.

And again, I saw a familiar being. A massive archangel, the one known as Gabriel, the Mighty King.

He was different now though. Seeming much smaller, appearing in front of me as I fell. He was still huge, easily the size of a few football stadiums stacked together... but not as large as I remember. No longer wielding his weapons and the Bible I had seen before, he wore a plain white set of robes, though they were pure and clean, as expected of an Archangel.

"You have returned." He spoke to me, his voice much softer and quieter than it was previously. "It would seem that you are in a dire circumstance, *Hero King*. Have you come to beg my aid?"

I smiled as I fell. "Yes. I am in dire need of your help. I am trapped, there are going to be big problems if I cannot escape. Will you lend me your power?"

Gabriel shook his head. "Ever since my companions and I were imprisoned in these rings, eons ago, we have never once lent our power to anyone. We were carried around first by the great Egyptian god of old, Horus, and later by the devil-like female known as Bahamut. While she was not a true demon or any evolved form of one, she was certainly a demonic being, one who won battles through lies and treachery."

I nodded as I fell past a thick cloud cover. "I am sorry that you were imprisoned in those rings. May I ask, what did you do to earn such a punishment?"

Gabriel's eyes lowered down below me, to the ground that I was falling towards and might never reach. "I... had to make a choice. A choice that was impossible to make. One that doomed my people to nigh-extinction. That choice... this is no punishment. My people were the ones who received the true anguish."

I stared at him, watching as his eyes filled with sorrow. "I... wish I could undo it. The angels may not have been mighty, and perhaps the gods were fools, but to have them all die off... it seems so cruel. So... awful."

Gabriel nodded. "But you know, things are not as they always seem. The Great War was not a normal war. It was caused by those who had profit to gain from it, as were all human wars fought over territory, riches, oil, women, and many other things of that sort. There is no such thing as pure evil in a war, only degrees of debauchery and immorality. And the angels... they were not above committing such vile acts."

Gabriel sighed deeply as he stared at my falling body. "I will not lend you my power, Hero King. I will *give* you my full power. Not just mine, but that of my two brothers as well. We have long ceased to be useful. Our kind only has one left, and it is up to you to protect her. She is the key to bringing balance between the three worlds. If you promise me to protect her, you will leave here no longer a man. You will become something *far above* such a level of mortality."

I hesitated. I'll... no longer be a man? Does he mean genderless, or no longer a human? I don't... know if I want that.

But... I owe the people that have fought under me and for me. I owe those who gave me safety and care for ten years. One spoiled ruler needs his discipline, and I have a clone to catch.

"Very well. I accept your terms, Gabriel. I will do whatever is in my power to end this war. I will bring balance back to our universe. If I fail... then perhaps it was never destined to begin with."

Gabriel stared at me solemnly. "Since you have agreed to my terms, these are my final words. Listen well. You are no longer the Hero king. As of this moment, your powers will advance you to a new unseen tier of immortality. You will call yourself the *God King* of humanity. Only two such beings in the past have ever had such titles. But you are our last hope. Farewell, God King. Do not squander your power. Our hope lies with you."

I raised my hand up and saluted the archangel. I'm not good with formalities, but this seemed to be the best way to communicate my respect for his position.

"Farewell, Gabriel. May we see each other eons in the future, as brothers."

Gabriel beamed broadly, as his body floated upwards into the sky. From above, a massive lance of light shot down, piercing my heart like a blade of molten metal. I screamed again in wordless agony, as millions of runes etched themselves into my body, their dark lettering blotting out the color of my pale skin, and then they turned bright white and disappeared as they embedded themselves into my very soul itself.

And suddenly, I was back in the jail cell. But something had noticeably changed.

I could see again.

Part 132: Colossus

My aura rippled with power. I felt overwhelmed by the amount of energy blasting out of every pore in my body. It was like I was a mountain top, and the energy fleeing my body was the water of Niagara Falls smashing down into a tiny soup bowl below.

With a single movement, my arms burst out of the strait-jacket. The clones left in the room started to take notice of me, but I was unbelievably fast now. In the blink of an eye, I had spun around with such force that the ropes hanging me from the ceiling exploded from the heat friction in the air, and I jerked my hands out, stopping myself.

Whipping around in midair, I landed lightly on my feet, and took four steps. Each step placed me in front of one of the four clones, and a single punch destroyed them, transforming them into lifeless matter on the walls. It was a cruel fate, but they're too weak for me to bother with reintegrating, and I still lack the ability to speak.

* * *

Two seconds later, the door barring my room smashed off its hinges, flying forward and burying itself four feet into the opposite wall. The stone that covered the wall was shattered, and the soft earth behind it was not dense enough to slow the door down quickly. The impact made everything around me rumble, including the ground and other prison doors.

Holy fucking shit, I am powerful. When I punch things, I don't even feel it! My body is way beyond the strength of iron at this point. It's like I took a training regiment of insane requirements and started doing it nonstop for a few eternities. How did angels lose the war if they possessed this kind of power?!

Thinking that thought, I glanced down at the three rings on my hand. The names of the angels were no longer there. They had lost their power.

But I won't take them off. I'll wear them, in memorial of those who gave their lives to protect me. I won't fail you, Gabriel, Michael and Raphael.

I jerk my head to the side just in time to see a knife fly past my head. One of my clones is there, summoning knives in the distance. Ordinarily I couldn't see him with my eyes, but my eyes are beyond perfect now. I have telescopic, microscopic, Xray, and Heat-sensing vision, to name a few. And weirdly enough, I see all of them at one time.

To be honest, it's actually a downgrade over my spatial vision, but I can regain that back once my voice gets returned. For now, I only have speed and power, and my vision, or, do I?

As another knife flies at me, I jerk my hand up and snatch it out of midair. Then I spread my legs out in a rock-steady foot position, arch my arms apart, and *clap* them together. A wave of forces surges forwards, smashing my clone backward. He snaps his neck instantly when he hits the wall. One down, a few thousand more to go.

My clones are still important for maintaining this city though. It's not the citizens that are at fault here, it's *Adams*. Quickly looking in all directions with my enhanced vision, I spot a small troop of men running down the stairs. My body darkens as I press myself against the wall, blending in with the shadows. Neat, I'm discovering new powers all the time.

As the men run past, I lightly tap my foot in the ground and silently leap at the doorway. Landing in a roll, I climb up the rotating stairwell in 4 more steps, pinning my body between the walls above the door as I again blend in with the shadows. Another group of soldiers charges through whispering to each other about "Neutralizing the rogue clone."

Hmm? What's this? I've got a very bad feeling this won't be as easy to resolve as I'd like.

I luck out, the next group of troops, while bigger, is around a corner in the distance. I jump down through the doorway from my vantage point on the ceiling, dart forwards, and jump up again, my grip easily allowing me to hold onto a massive pillar that reaches up into the roof. *Am I Spiderman or something?*

I'm super strong, super fast, nimble, and have the ability to blend into shadow. I've definitely powered up. But I've gotten lucky so far. The real test will be recovering my voice.

As the soldiers run past, I scan the area with my eyesight. Lots of red life signatures, and a bunch of black ones. I assume the black ones are my clones? Have their powers been corrupted? I thought they always had a holy aura?

This is not good. I was only unconscious for a couple days. How has so much changed?

Once the soldiers below me have disappeared into the prison system below me, I jump down, leaping forwards towards the prison cell for females. If I'm lucky, maybe Cassiel will be down there.

But I come to a screeching halt, as I run into one of my clones again, standing beside Adams and a full squad of men. Hm? Aren't these the Yellow Squad members?

They eyeball me suspiciously as they level their weapons at me. "Slayer! Is that the one?"

The clone quickly responds. "Yes! That's him! It's Hope, you have to catch him!"

Wait, he's pretending to be the original?! Shit, that son of a bitch.

Part 133: Rogue Clone

King Adams warned me that there was a rogue clone on the loose. "Hope has gained sentience and turned against us, this is your fault, you guys need to help me stop him."

But I didn't expect to see this.

Slayer stood next to me as he pointed at the... *thing* in front of me. It was covered in grotesque, pulsing tattoos that changed from light to dark and back again. They seemed to be alive, crawling all around in his skin, sometimes fading away and then reappearing.

And his eyes... they were glowing a bright white, something I had heard they used to do many years ago, before he battled with and killed the Dark Witch. But those were just rumors.

This *thing* in front of me, whatever happened to this clone, it was terrifying!

Colonel Cody, now a much higher ranked military commander thanks to his tactics for combating the Grez, turned to me. "Get him, Saul! Get him!"

I leaped into action, whipping my Buddha Palm forwards. As I leaped, I deftly jerked my other hand around and slapped an Orange level canister into the firing compartment. 75% power, this is the biggest blast I've ever used before.

BOOOOOM!

A blast of fire and air, a literal inferno from hell, leaped out of my forward-facing palm, smashing right into the disgusting mutant clone.

And he ate the blast oh my god.

He somehow opened his mouth and sucked it all in, preventing even the slightest damage to anything around him, himself included.

"What the fuck?! What did you do, Hope?! How did you get that strong?!" Slayer yelled from the side at the clone in front of me.

The clone wordlessly held his hand up at me, and I jerked back, expecting some kind of attack.

"He attacked Saul! Gunther, you're up!" Colonel Cody yelled at Gunther, and the big hulking man charged at the 7 foot tall titan of a man in front of us.

Activating his rocket fist, he blasted forwards at inhuman speeds towards the clone, but in the blink of an eye, the clone jerked his hand up, caught the glove, and *crushed it* without any perceivable effort.

Slayer aimed his hand at the clone while he was distracted. " **DIE!** "

Nothing happened, and the clone whipped his head around to look at Slayer. Spotting what was apparently his real target, he leaped at Slayer to attack him as Slayer jumped backwards. While jumping back, Slayer yelled again. "VANISH!"

And instantly, his body disappeared.

I heard noises moving around, clearly an invisible Slayer, but I had no idea where he was. However, the clone seemed to follow him with its eyes and jumped after him. Yeah, that's definitely a clone. Slayer can't see a thing, he has to use that weird spatial vision of his. I've heard it explained but I don't understand it. What I do know is that this clone is not casting any word spells at all, so someone must have been experimenting on him or something.

"Shit, you can still follow me with your eyes? How did you get so strong, monster?!"

A voice sounded off near me, but I couldn't tell where it came from. Gunther was now weeping in agony at his nearly severed fist, as the metal had been crushed into his hand and it was impossible to get out.

I called over a nearby clone. "Get him out of this gauntlet and heal his hand!"

The clone didn't nod or anything, but quickly repaired and healed it and Gunther was back to full health in no time, though he kept wincing, likely due to the phantom pain.

But this battle... this is one I shall not forget for the rest of my life.

Part 134:

I chased after Hope. He's got everyone fooled good, though I'm sure the high ranking generals who were at that table know who he is, as does Adams. This must be at the highest levels and nothing below.

However, Hope was already only 50% my normal strength when I summoned him. Now that I'm unfathomably stronger, he's going to be falling to pieces as quickly as all the other clones. I'm having trouble hitting him though, because his spatial vision and apparent intelligence is quite high.

Strange though, now that I think about it, Adams had said that he gave the Crown to a youth from a developed world, and that youth made the 3D holomap. But that doesn't make sense, I've yet to see a single human world developed beyond the medieval ages. Why is that, I wonder? And what if it was this clone, 'Hope', that he gave the crown to? And why would he do that? So many questions, but I'm in the middle of the battle, so it has to wait. I will get my answers later.

Hope quickly cast back-to-back spells. "Speed! Slow! Hkjgfh-!"

I didn't hear the last word, because suddenly he was gone. Little fucker, stealing my battle tactics. I was suddenly rammed from the back, the front, and the sides! It hurt a little bit, but honestly not that much.

And... I grinned menacingly. *Stupid little shit*, you can't cast those two spells together or they will devour your energy rapidly. It's worse if you're a clone since you have such a small pool to work with, and to top it off, you've already wasted a bit of your energy doing other fruitless bullshit like making yourself invisible.

Sure enough, he came to a grinding halt and fell to the ground, feet away from me, panting with exhaustion.

"Haahh... hahhhhh.... shit, this is bad..."

Yeah, no kidding, dumbfuck. I've fought many battles over the last 11 years. You may be my clone, but I was wrong about you. You're *dumber* than I am.

He glanced back over his shoulder and saw me slowly walking at him. "Adams! A little help here please?!"

I glanced over and laughed a silent laugh since I can't produce any sound. Adams was trembling, seeing the state of my clone on the ground. Oh this is just too *good*. What a perfect

way to end the day. I hope you're shitting yourself, little man. I don't let anyone betray me and get away with it. *Not anymore.*

As I turned back to my clone, I reached down slowly and precisely, as I watched his expression grow in horror. He knew what was coming. You think you can just get away with this? Not so fast.

Suddenly, Adams called out to me. "Get your hands away from him. If you don't, we'll execute your friend."

I paused. Hmm? Wait, could he mean-?!

I glanced back over at Adams. He was standing in front of the group of men with a picture drawn of Cassiel. It was quite beautiful, to be honest, clearly made by a top tier artist. The others behind him couldn't see the picture, and they must have figured it wasn't their business, because they weren't trying to.

"Get back in your cage, or she gets *the knife*."

This is very unlike Adams. Even if she's not a human, he hates killing unless it's demons. This is very unlike him. Is he being mind-control-

Oh. So that's it. I halt and stand up straight, turning back to glare at Hope. You monster, have you mind controlled all my clones, the King, and other officers at the top? You're truly a foul demon. I have to send you back to the void whence you came.

Just as I was about to collect my energy to punch him hard enough to shatter concrete, a smile suddenly bursts onto his face.

"Ahaha, I just had a great idea!"

Huh? What is he talking about-?!

He quickly speaks a single word.

" Reintegrate!!! "

A suction of energy from all corners of the city blasts through the corridors and hallways of the castle, as I feel a monumental amount of energy surge into his body.

"Ha... haha... HAHAHAAAAHA!!!" Hope cackles evilly, as he nimbly jumps up into a standing position. "Fantastic! That was a great idea!"

I look him up and down in surprise. Rivers of energy are flowing out of him, just the same as energy flows out of me. What the fuck?! Did he reintegrate every clone in the city into himself?! CLONES CAN REINTEGRATE OTHER CLONES?! Not good, not good at all!!

And then I see him step forwards, and with a light tap on my cheek, he sends me smashing through three sets of walls.

Part 135:

My chest heaved and my breath silently escaped as I gasped for air. My clothes were in tatters. Thankfully, Hope was in no better of a position. We've been fighting for thirty straight minutes. Entire sections of the castle are destroyed. He's as badly beaten up as I am. Having absorbed god only knows how many clones, he's unbelievably powerful. But it seems the heroic facade he was putting up in front of the troops is gone now.

We're up on the flat roof of the castle, using it as a battle arena. There are craters everywhere, parts of the roof are sagging or outright collapsed... this place is a mess.

Hope gasps for air as he stares me down with his unseeing hollowed out eyes. "This is... your fault... you know."

My eyes narrow. Hm? He's got something to say?

"You kept playing god. You summoned clone after clone, with no thought of the consequences, forcing us to be meatshields for inferior beings. The whole time, you thought to yourself 'This is convenient!', but you never asked *our* opinions. You didn't care. We were just stupid puppets to you. And now look how it's come back to bite you in the ass. Ha... hahah..."

I lower my head a little. He is right. I took my abilities for granted. I thought the clones were brainless mute beings who followed orders. Maybe... they were like Beelzebub, stuck in puppet mode. Maybe they were waiting for me to give them freedom to move. A lot of 'maybes' come to my mind, but I know one thing for certain. I messed up.

This clone is incredibly powerful.

He continued speaking. "You made many mistakes, but your biggest mistake was your *stupidity*. Didn't you notice anything wrong with yourself when you summoned clone after clone? They weren't just copying you, they were taking bits and pieces of you, from the outer layers of your heart, to the innermost layers. And as for me? I lucked out. I got the deepest, darkest corner of your heart. You've felt it take over once before. Do you remember it?"

I hesitated. Was he referring to... when I fought Amelia and Blaarjiim... all those years ago? Wait... did those dark pieces of weaponry plant something inside me? Did-

As thought roil in my head, Hope laughs. "Haha, I can practically hear those gears turning in your head. We're not so different, you and I. We both hate *people*. We both hate *humanity* as a whole, we both hate *annoying little girls*. We just want to be cool and have people admire us

from a distance. It's great having fangirls following us around, isn't it? The problem is when they get too close."

He stared into my eyes with his unseeing hollow husks. "You know what I'm talking about. *Nuisances*. Always asking you for orders, telling you their plans, and so on and so forth. Hell, you let two innocent men get devoured by Amelia, just because you didn't *really* want to help. Am I right? Who's the real demon here?"

I suddenly staggered and fell to the ground, as waves of nausea hit me. Jesus Christ. He's right. I've done so many horrible things. It makes no sense that archangels would trust me with their power. What the hell am I?! I'm a demon in human form! Half the time, I want to kill all of humanity just because of all the problems they cause me. It's... no wonder Adams didn't trust me. I'm wrong for faulting him.

But I hold down the nausea and look up. Hope looks so smug. Adams may be mind controlled, but Hope is still a monster. After I kill him, after I defeat this thing... I'm going to leave here. Humanity will be fine without me. I need to go my own way. I need to leave these humans behind.

From inside me, I feel something appearing. It's... a voice? It's a voice. And it reminds me of a voice I heard long ago.

God King. You've always had evil in your heart. But you fought to contain it. You fought to be one with it. You won't let a liar and a deceiver tell you about how bad you are, will you? You're only human, you've made mistakes, and you are preventing them. Be easier on yourself.

"Michael?" I speak aloud, suddenly jumping when I realize my voice works. What?! My voice works?! HOW?

I will give you my own parting gift. You did not come to see me, but I came to you. Speak your mind now, go forth, and become the savior that the world needs.

The voice faded away, and I was left alone with my thoughts.

Hope heard me speak. "Michael? Wait, shit, those damned rings!" He glances at my hand. "I forgot to cut your hand off! Shit, a slip of my memory will not be my downfall! Now it makes sense. Now I know why you're so fucking strong! You CHEATED!"

I raise my head. "I don't cheat, Hope. I always follow the rules. You, however, do not. I'll have to stop you from terrorizing the denizens of this universe, put a seal on you, and go back to living my life."

He jerked his hand up and aimed it at me. **"Silence!!"**

Nothing happened. "Thanks to the powers of the archangels, you can't use simple cheat words on me anymore. But... I can to you."

His eyes jerked open as he realized what I meant.

In the blink of an eye, my hand aimed at him. " *Reintegrate.* "

His mouth opened, but no sound came out. A second later, his energy rushed into my body.

And as powerful as I felt earlier, I feel unstoppable now.

I deftly jumped down to the palace grounds below me. *Cassiel.*

Part 136: Retribution

I calmly walked down the corridors of the castle, noting the horrific levels of destruction apparent everywhere. The titanic battle between Hope and I had caused incredible amounts of damage to the castle. The pillars in various areas were in ruins, the floors were littered with bits and pieces of rock, marble, and gold from the collapsed ceiling and destroyed walls... it was a mess.

Luckily, I could sense that nobody had been badly injured. Most of the people had fled when they heard the explosive sounds of our fight, and the few that remained were easily healed as I walked along. Most were unconscious, so I healed them and walked away before they woke up.

And then I arrived at Adams' chamber.

He stood in front of his doorway, with his left arm wrapped around Cassiel's throat, and his right arm holding a dagger to her heart.

"Don't come any closer, y-you monster! What did you do to..." He glanced to the side with his eyes, noting the presence of the Yellow Team. "...to Slayer?! Did you actually defeat him?!"

"It's all over, Adams." When I spoke, his head jerked back involuntarily; he obviously had not expected me to speak. "You're a pretty bad liar, old friend. And now you're holding a hostage. How far you have fallen."

I turned to look at Colonel Cody. "Doesn't something about this entire debacle strike you as strange, or are you in on this farce? Why are you defying the one who freed you from Bahamut? Why are you siding with a mentally deranged man?"

Cody suddenly looked uncomfortable, as he glanced at Adams, and then back to me.

I didn't wait for his response. "Adams. There are two ways out of this. The easy way, and the *really* easy way. Think about what you're doing; you're a smart man."

Adams hesitated, as his eyes jerked around. He was very nervous, and acting very... ' *un-Adamlike* '. "Y-you can't fool me! Stay away, you monster!"

I slowly walked towards him, the distance between us was about a half of a football field. "Think, Adams! If you stab and kill her, I'll become *very* pissed. I'll tear you limb from limb, do you understand me? You'll lose your hostage AND your life! But, if you give her up quietly, I won't kill you. How about it? Are you that desperate to have me take out some anger on you?"

Cassiel wriggled a little as he pressed the knife right up against her skin. I noticed that her arms and wings were bound tightly behind her, and her mouth was gagged. The sight filled me

with anger. Once again, she was bound by a disgusting piece of filth. Adams started breathing quickly. He didn't know what to do. He realized the logic of my words. This was a no-win situation. He would lose either way.

"I have a question for you." Saul, the man who I recalled wielding the prototype 'Buddha Palm', spoke to me. "Adams told us that a clone you had summoned for us, one we named 'Hope', - he had gone berserk, and needed to be contained. He told us it had gained sentience, and it was unable to be reintegrated but... I'm beginning to doubt that story. Can you explain what's going on?"

Adams' eyes darted towards Saul. He clearly didn't want me answering those questions, but to speak up now would be damning evidence of my claims.

I nodded at Saul. "I'm not sure exactly what was going on up here, but I left and entered the labyrinth a few days ago, and met Cassiel, that angel over there, in the labyrinth. I rescued her, appeared here, and was attacked and betrayed by Adams. It all happened so fast, I'm still not even sure what happened."

Adams' entire body was shaking a little bit. Cassiel looked at me, silently imploring me to get her away from that madman.

I shrugged. "Ah, well. It's unfortunate, Adams. You're making me do this the hard way."

With the barest tiniest of motion, I suddenly appeared in front of Adams and Cassiel, my body moving at an ungodly and unexpected speed. Adams *screamed* in terror, as I slapped the knife out of his hands, the impact instantly breaking his wrist. In the next instant, I grabbed hold of the arm he was holding Cassiel with, and crushed it by barely flexing my hand at all.

If the scream from my appearance was bad, the howl of agony after I destroyed both his arms... It felt *delicious*. Very satisfying.

" **AAAAAAAAAUYYUUYUGHHHHH!!** " Adams fell to the ground, writhing in agony, as I pulled Cassiel close to me, and with a single motion undid the ropes that bound her.

She smiled up at me thankfully, as she pulled the gag out of her mouth. "Hero! You saved me!"

I nodded. Then I looked over at the members of the Yellow team. "Do you men have anything to say?"

Cody immediately bowed his head. "No, Slayer. I apologize for the misunderstanding. I would do more, but I can't think of a big enough way to apologize. We will take care of the traitor now."

I nodded but then paused. "Hold a moment."

I walked over to Adams, who was now sobbing on the ground. My voice filled with ice and venom. " *Give me the crown. Now.* "

He whimpered when he saw my demonic glowing white eyes and the tattoo's on my body turned pitch black as my anger slightly boiled over. Quickly looking at his arms and back up to me, he whimpered something unintelligible.

I glared deeply at him. "I know you can't move your arms, you stupid piece of shit. Give me verbal permission, or I'll just take your head off right fucking now."

I suddenly tried to contain my laughter as his pants suddenly moistened and he quickly babbled. "YersyesIgiveyoupermissiontotakethe-thecrowngorightahead!!!"

Stifling a smile at the pathetic image of a man I once called friend, I snatched the crown off his head and placed it on mine.

" *Pray* you never see me again."

And with that, I walked away, heading towards my house. Yellow Team stared in awe at me, as I walked away, hand in hand with a beautiful angel.

I'm done with these humans. I will forge my own destiny away from them. I will go home, grab Hoarhiim's orb, store it in my infinite container, and never return.

* * *

As we approached my house, I chatted with Cassiel, learning of what had transpired. She had been captured, taken to a secret room even I didn't know about, tied up, and interrogated for almost 48 hours straight. As an angel, she didn't need sleep, only spiritual and thought energy, so she was easily interrogated right up until they brought her out to me.

But... based on the fresh markings on her arms and legs, I could tell. They didn't just ask for information politely. They must have tortured her. The thought... made my blood boil.

As we approached my house, we spoke of other things, but I noticed something odd. There was a heat signature in my house. It was cold, maybe food lying on the ground? Hard to tell.

I rushed up to my front door and as I opened it, my heart halted.

Phoebe was lying on the floor, a knife stabbed into her heart.

Her body was cold.

Part 137: Stages Of Grief

In a flash, I'm at Phoebe's side. I duck down and wrap my left arm behind her and my right hand grabs the knife.

"Phoebe... don't be dead don't be dead please don't be dead..."

I pull the knife out quickly and cast a spell. " **HEAL!!** "

But the wound doesn't close. My lip is quivering. She's been dead for a long time now. Her body is completely cold and it's very stiff. Rigor mortis has set in.

No. NO! I won't let her just die. I have POWER now! I have the powers of literal angels and gods in my body! I can't accept this! I can't!!

" *Resurrect! Revive! Energize! Recover! Reanimate! Enliven!* **Invigorate!! Resuscitate!! REVITALIZE! RESTORE!!!!** "

For ten minutes, I try every word I know. Nothing works. Tears are pouring out. Fuck. I CAN'T SAVE HER! It's been too long!

Cassiel watches, with her head hanging down low as she sees me trying to revive Phoebe. For the twenty minutes that she knew Phoebe, she barely even had seen who she was, yet she feels sad for me.

...What happened? Why is she dead? Why is this happening to me? What did she do to deserve this? Questions... so many questions...

But... as I look to her left side, I see something that makes my heart stop. Her left hand... on the opposite side of the body from where I sit... there's something written in blood. Her left hand trails off on the last letter... but there's no mistaking it.

I love Hero

Fuck.... no... she's dead... I wasn't even there for her and she still wrote she loves me... fuck, why would she- GODDAMNIT!

Grief is hitting my body in waves as I hold the body of the woman who has faithfully been at my side for 11 years. I've failed her in every inconceivable way and she was on my side, even up to the very end.

But... wait. Wait... maybe I can't revive her but... perhaps I could do something else. Puppet won't work if I don't kill someone myself, especially not on someone dead this long... but her memories may still exist.

Quickly gathering myself, I aim my right hand at her head. " **MEMORIES!** "

In a flash, her remaining few memories rush into my head.

* * *

An ocean. I sit next to an ocean, waiting for the ship to arrive. Soon, I will be shipped out, along with the other slaves. The King of Egypt is a very cruel man, from what I've heard.

I don't want to go, but I have no choice. I've never had a choice.

* * *

I stand at attention, as the lady of the house inspects each new arrival. She frowns when she sees me, as they all do. It's only normal, I'm uglier than most female slaves. I consider this a boon however. The pretty ones get sent to the bedchambers, but no man has ever wanted me, so I get sent to the kitchen. Since I love cooking, I don't mind... it's better than it could be.

Ah, no! I spilled the main entree all over the floor! Oh gods, he's going to be furious!

* * *

"What? Who are you?" I speak to the strange mermaid looking creature.

She glares down at me. "You're a pathetic looking one. My name doesn't matter, but you must answer my riddle. If you don't answer correctly, I will enslave you for all eternity."

I nod. "That's fine. I've always been a slave. What's the difference between one master or a different one?"

* * *

Huh? I'm not a harpy anymore? When did this happen? I look up and spot the image of a man, standing over the badly mangled body of the creature that transformed me in a monster. He holds a bright white orb and laughs as he kicks her corpse.

I have a feeling about this one.

* * *

Adams is looking away from me. "Oh. Hm, yes. Now that I think about it, you did change your name, didn't you. How *careless* of me."

He turns back to me. "Everyone in the castle knows that you're a little more than friends with 'Hero' or whatever he calls himself by now."

I glance back at Hero. "Huh? W-what are you talking about, Adams? You're acting strange."

Hero sees me looking at him, and a strange, *ugly* looking smile appears on his face. Huh? That's not a smile I've ever seen before.

"Wait... you're not Hero. You're a.. a clone! But then, if you're a clone, why are you talking normally?"

The clone grins evilly at me. "Why indeed? Ah, such is the way of life. Poor Phoebe, you're just a normal woman who wants to get to know a man. Unfortunately, you're too smart for your own good."

Adams sighs. "I'm sorry, Phoebe. Hero is out of the picture now. This is Hope that you're talking to, a different person entirely. He will be the one who saves humanity. But you? You know too much."

I jerk back over to look at Adams, watching as he clicks the lock on the door.

" *Silence.*" 'Hope' or whatever his name is casts a spell on me. I try to speak, but nothing comes out.

Hope's grin disappears. "Well, you won't be able to scream for help now. I'm sorry to tell you this, Phoebe. As a clone of the man you love, I have to be the bearer of bad news. *He never loved you.* And soon, he'll never be able to either. I hope you've made your peace."

Ah! A sharp pain in... my chest... huh? Why is Adams... stabbing me? Why...

* * *

I feel a new emotion inside me now. Phoebe's memories are scattered and disjointed, but her last ones are crystal clear. *Adams.* I... was going to let you live. Even if you were mind controlled or not... I was going to forgive past grievances... but *this*.

THIS IS THE FINAL STRAW!

Rage encapsulates me as this final betrayal flashes through my mind. I aim my hand at Phoebe's body. " *Storage.*" I will bury her later.

For now, I have something *I really must do.*

I rise up and turn to Cassiel, who has been staring blankly at me the whole time this happened. Something is wrong though. Her face isn't just blank, it's... covered in something. Wait, there's two Cassiels? Three?!

All around me suddenly, Cassiel is everywhere, as her face and aura darkens.

" **Ha... haha... I'm back, 'God King'. You didn't think I'd leave so easily, did you?**
"

That voice... it's... Hope?!

"I killed you!" I scream at the voice coming from Cassiels' lips. Her aura has visibly darkened.

" Calm down, fool. If you lash out and strike me down, you'll kill the woman you're supposed to protect. I'm just a mental reincarnation of Hope. Did you think absorbing me along with every dark clone in the city wouldn't have any negative repercussions? GET REAL! Every clone in the city was under my control! "

I suddenly realized what had happened. "Wait, so when I reintegrated you, you didn't actually-?"

" Hehehe... that's right. I'm now a darkness permanently in your heart. But let's ignore that for a moment. Aren't you fucking PISSED right now? Adams killed a woman who had been at your side for 11 years. Are you going to let him get away with that? "

I shook my head slowly. "No... no you mind controlled him. It's your fault. Adams was never like this before!"

" Oh come now, you don't actually believe that, do you? I never had to control Adams. He was a monster all along. You were simply too blind to see. If you kill him though, you will truly understand. "

"What the hell are you yammering on about?! Stop playing games with me, give me back Cassiel!"

" I'm only using her as a means of projecting myself so we can speak face-to-face. In actuality, I'm a hallucination. A figment of your imagination. Right now you're yelling and she doesn't know why. You're yelling at her and scaring her. You're *crazy* now, you know? "

I paused. He's right. I'm letting him goad me. Shit... I reintegrated the clones and now they must be making me evil or something. But... whether that's the case or not...

I just really want to tear Adams' heart out.

Energy surges from my body, as the combined powers of all my clones, the three archangels, and leftover energy remnants from Hoarhiim surge inside me.

I jump back to my room in two rapid steps, grabbing his orb.

Goodbye, Hero City. And even moreso... **goodbye, Adams.**

Part 138:

I don't know what I'm about to do.

I loathe Adams. I hate him. I want him dead. He killed someone I cared about dearly. I can't say I loved Phoebe, but she was certainly important to me.

Cassiel followed along beside me as we walked towards the castle, one more time.

She kept glancing over at me nervously, and then looking away again. I don't know what to say though, I probably seemed like a psychotic mess, talking to nobody at all.

"Ah... Hero...? I um..." She suddenly spoke out, as we walked. She hesitated, not sure of what to say.

I slowed down and came to a stop as I faced her. "Yes, Cassiel?"

I couldn't help but notice now that I had my eyesight back... Cassiel was more than just a pretty angel, she was actually stunning, to say the least. As I had thought before, her hair was pure white, a little longer than shoulder length, and perfectly straight. She had blue eyes, and she was still wearing those full body white silken robes she was wearing when I first saw her, though my repair job had made them perfectly sewn again.

"That woman... did you love her?"

I hesitated before replying. "...No. But, she was a dear friend. And I know she loved me."

I looked down at the ground. Cassiel swallowed quietly. "Do you feel guilty about her death?"

I nodded quietly as I stared at a flower behind Cassiel. "...Yes. I feel incredibly guilty. She died just because she knew my name. She died because of my actions... my lack of foresight... my lack of preparation, even."

Cassiel nodded silently. "You shouldn't blame yourself. You didn't kill her... it's not your fault."

I looked up into Cassiel's eyes. She's a good girl... but she doesn't understand. "Cassiel, if a man stabs another man, that makes him a murderer. But if a king orders another man to stab that same man, is the king absolved of the crime?"

Cassiel, previously a human, and likely familiar with the concept of law and order, paused for a second. Finally she shook her head. "No... I suppose not."

"Alright. And what if the king sees many signs that his subject will be stabbed to death by another person, but he chooses not to imprison or interrogate the murderer before it happens?"

Is he still absolved of blame?"

Cassiel lowered her head. "Ah... well, I suppose... he would still be, um... guilty..."

I smiled gently. "Exactly. I'm guilty, then. I indirectly killed Phoebe with my inaction."

My face hardened as I spoke. "But I can't let that happen again. I'm still just a child at heart. I have to take responsibility not just for my actions, but my lack of action as well."

With that, I took her hand in mine and we continued walking towards the castle.

We arrived at the prison section within 15 minutes. Quietly walking together after receiving directions from one of the guards we arrive at the cell that is holding Adams.

Both of his arms are in slings, and he's clearly in pain. I'd heal him up under normal circumstances, but I love seeing him *squirm*. He's sitting down on the cold floor, as he currently has no bed. The cell is totally empty. *Perfect*. Leave him here with his thoughts.

"Adams. I'll make this short and sweet. Did... did you kill Phoebe?"

He continues to stare at the ground numbly. "Yes. I did."

I feel my anger rising. He isn't even trying to apologize. This... son of a bitch...

I grab the bars and shake them fiercely. "You're not even going to look me in the eye?! What the fuck is wrong with you?! Where did I go wrong in choosing you?!"

I screamed as I shook the bars. Adams continued staring ahead at the ground. "I... don't know why it ended up like this. I don't remember when I stopped being a good ruler of the people. I don't remember... it just changed, all of a sudden."

I stopped shaking the bars, as I looked down at the broken man in front of me. This... this doesn't seem right. I knew Adams for more than ten years... he never was the kind of man to do these things.

Adams suddenly looked up into my eyes. "Kill me."

I froze. *What?* He wants me to- what?! "Why would you say that all of a sudden? Do you have a death wish?!"

Adams shrugged and went back to looking at the floor. "We've known each other for ten years, God King. I was somehow *changed*. I'm not myself. I'm a different man now. And I just don't know why."

I nodded sagely, as I felt some anger disappear. I don't know why, but I agree with him. He's not the same. Maybe Hope corrupted him. It almost sounds like a bad joke to say that, but it seems to be the truth.

I aimed my hand at him. "Very well. I very much want to kill you for what you did to Phoebe... but also, as an old friend, I won't let you just rot in a cell. Between those two things, under my power as the God King, I sentence you to death. And as a small mercy, I will make it a quick one."

Tears formed in Adams eyes as he stared at the ground. "...Thank you. You truly are... a good friend."

"Goodbye, Adams."

With a single word, he was dead. " *Die.* "

But as he died, something horrifying happened.

His body turned into dust. In the same way a clone of mine would.

No... no no no! NO! This... this wasn't the real Adams! This must have been...

Part 139:

Clones. I've been playing a dangerous game for too long a time.

I never thought about all the implications of creating clones. I never asked enough questions.

Using the power of the crown, I've started analyzing what I know. I've figured out a surprising number of things. For instance:

-I can have any number of clones active at once, but after a certain number, they stop being distinct signals I can follow in real time, and become like a crowd of people making a lot of noise.

-Furthermore, as clones increase in number, the amount of 'stuff' they take from me (Hope said it was pieces of my heart, but whatever it is, it's still *something*) increases, possibly exponentially. This leaves me even further in a foggy and clouded daze.

-Clones aren't actually stupid. I don't know exactly what happened due to reabsorbing the memories of thousands of them at once, but I think someone ordered Hope, or possibly asked Hope, to develop his own personality. I'm not sure to what end, or how much direction they gave him, but the end was disastrous.

-Furthermore, as it turns out, the clones are normal human beings. I essentially summon them in a puppet mode, and they have no ability to react to stimuli unless ordered. They feel pain, emotions, and everything else, but lack any ability to respond... this must be hell for them.

-I can also figure out, based on how I might react if I was a puppet, that this garnered a lot of resentment among the clones. Whichever clone 'Hope' was (Why did he have a normal name?) he was probably angry at being treated like livestock, and when someone decided to order him to develop a personality, he developed one based on revenge and hatred.

But... still. There is that matter of back when I was overcome by the dark artifacts. Might the rage and lack of control have stayed with me? Might the insanity have buried itself inside me, waiting for a chance to reawaken?

I'm thinking a lot harder than I usually do... very strange. I don't usually ponder things this much. Might this have something to do with the archangels? Perhaps the clones I reintegrated increased not just my spirit power vastly, but my mental power as well? I'm not sure, but there seems to be a lot more brainpower here than I remember.

I glance over at Cassiel. She's still staring at the spot where Adams vanished from. When I look at her, she turns back to me and smiles weakly. "Oh... I'm sorry about your friend... that

must have been very sad for you."

I shake my head. "No, this may just be good news. That was not my friend, that was a clone of my friend."

I took a few minutes to explain to her what my powers of wordsmithing entailed, diving in-depth into my cloning abilities. She nodded over and over, asking for elaboration in a few areas.

"So, as long as it's a single word, you can make anything happen if there's a literal, or even a stretched interpretation?"

I shrugged. "Yeah, that's basically how it works."

"Ohhh. Then, um, why not picture Adams' face in your mind, and try a word like 'Locate'?"

I stared at Cassiel blankly. You're kidding. That's... THAT'S GENIUS! How did she come up with that so quickly? I've underestimated a being that has lived for millions of years! Come to think of it, Adams was smart as well, and he lived for millions of years as a monster. Perhaps if you're smart, you continue getting smarter and smarter as time goes on, even up to an eternity.

Well anyway, it's worth a shot. " **Locate.** "

Instantly, a red dot appears on my mental map of the castle. The crown shows me his exact spot.

It's... he's... standing a mile or so out behind the castle? That's odd. Why is he there?

I take Cassiel's hand again. I'm getting quite used to this, and she doesn't seem to mind in the slightest. " *Teleport.* "

In a flash, we've arrived! We're in an open field but... Adams is nowhere to be seen. I look all over the place, but even with my vision, I don't see him.

"Oh! God King, look!"

Cassiel points at the ground that we're standing on... the dirt has been disturbed.

Almost like... something was buried here. No... no...

I see something buried a few feet under the dirt. It's... a corpse...

Part 140: Adams

I stare down at the corpse below me. It seems to be in otherwise normal condition, thought I can only see the bones with my X-ray vision.

I don't have anything like DNA testing in this world, and nobody here is smart enough to know how to do an autopsy but... there's no stab wound or anything.

W-what if... what if Hope became normal, and took action by killing Adams with a 'Die' spell, then teleported the both of them here while I was away, buried Adams, returned to the castle, and found the clone, then made the clone normal? Then he could simply tell the clone some lies or something... Adams' clone was not mind controlled. It would probably suffer from the same resentment and issues as my clone did, since we effectively set it to the side...

Ah... I just don't know anymore. Too many things are happening. This goes too deep. This *cuts* too deep.

I've lost too many people today. I can't even feel sad about Adams' death. He and Phoebe were... my closest friends and confidantes. Now that I am fairly sure it was the clone and not Adams doing the betraying...

I just don't know anymore. People die around me. So many people die. Will all of humanity die, because of me? Will Cassiel? I steal a glance at her, she's still staring at me, wondering what's going on. Oh, I forgot to explain it to her.

"Cassiel, Adams, the king, he's also dead. As in... he's really dead. Someone buried him right here."

She quickly steps off the patch of dirt. "Oh that's awful! Why are so many people dying?" She seems genuinely hurt. A man she's never met before, and she feels sorrow for him. Hell, the clone of the man had her tortured and interrogated for two days straight, and she *still* feels some sadness for his passing. At this point, this angel is more human than I am.

"It is, Cassiel. Let's head back to the castle. I have some questions I need to be asking."

* * *

The Yellow Team stood in front of me now. I explained to them the situation as I knew it. As I spoke, my eyes happened to notice an insanely beautiful woman in their group, quietly eyeballing me up and down as she licked her lips. And she was wearing a surprisingly small amount of clothing... and she had a little tail swinging around. Like, a demonic tail with a

tapered tip at the end. I know some monsters came to this capital, but her presence is surprising.

Colonel Cody rubbed his eyes. "So... we've been under the orders of a clone of the king for a long time now? Not the actual king?"

I nodded. "I believe so. I don't have all the answers, I was hoping you guys or some of the generals might know."

Saul spoke up next. "Our apologies, God King. We were likely the ones to name that clone, the one called "Hope". We did not intend for things to end up like this."

I frowned as I turned to him. "You named the clone? You didn't give him a designation? Why not?"

Saul shrugged. You created him right there in the maze, and we just... we didn't feel it was right to name what appeared to be a fully living being after a set of numbers and letters. It seemed... cruel."

I nodded. "We know now that it would eventually lead up to a bad ending... but we didn't know then. Don't be so hard on yourself, Saul. Your group did what you thought was right. In the end, the fault lies with me."

Cody coughed as a thought came to mind. "Listen, uh, 'God King'. We have a new problem in any case. Without your clones, we will be badly losing the war effort. Even now, there are reports coming in of many of our forces being slaughtered by the previously weakened Grez. Hell, the Grez alone might be manageable, but now we're dealing with mixed forces. Clones may be out of the question, but surely there must be something you can do to aid us?"

I pondered this. Taking account of the crown, I decided to try something new. "Yellow team, come with me."

We entered the War Room, now in shambles due to the fight between Hope and I earlier. I grimaced, this was not a pretty sight. "Give me a minute."

I once again buffed myself. " *Detect! Infrared! Sonar! Tracking! Targeting! Perception!* "

I paused. No... we can do better than that. I aimed my hand at my head. " *Enhance! Enhance! Enhance!* "

Suddenly, my brain was positively *swimming* in information as I reeled backwards. Giving myself more than a couple minutes for my head to stop spinning, I stared at the rubble in front of me. Aiming my spatial vision at every inch of the palace at once, I cast a very strong spell.

" **RECONSTRUCT!!!** "

The palace rapidly reformed itself around us, as magical amounts of marbled, stone, and gold sprouted out from pillars, broken section of walls, quickly rebuilding the castle all around us.

"Perfect. Let's have a seat."

The floor was still dirty, but I cleaned it with a single word. I'll let the maids and servants get the rest of the castle, they always need some work to do anyway.

Sitting down, I formed a meditative position, as eyes in the room locked onto my sitting form. In front of us, the holomap floated above the Great Table.

Somehow, I believe Hope had created this holomap by enhancing his mind, with the power of the crown. But if he can do it, I can as well.

And then it came to me. After about thirty minutes of meditation while my brain started simulating thousands of battles, thousands of scenarios, and many other such things, I opened my eyes and looked at the men. "I now see how we can win this war without my clones."

Cody stared at me intently. "How? I should very much like to know!"

Everyone in the room nodded eagerly.

"It's simple. We need some new... *toys*."

Part 141:

I spoke with Colonel Cody and got a good explanation of my plans over to him with some drawings and sketches. Cody eagerly devoured the knowledge.

"This... this won't just win the war, this will be a crushing victory."

I nodded. "I know. If I weren't so stupid, we'd have done this sooner."

Cody waved it off. "You're not stupid, not at all. Maybe you were naive, but you learn from your mistakes. As for Phoebe..." He glanced away from me in embarrassment. "I didn't know her, but... I hope you can find it in yourself to forgive yourself."

Cody glanced over at Cassiel, then back to me. "You're actually in a um, a pretty good position right now, you know?"

I sighed. "Yeah, if you say so."

Cassiel was chatting with Saul and the demon girl I'd noticed from earlier. I thanked Cody for his time and left him with my sketches, walking over to Cassiel and the other two.

Before I'd gotten within ten steps of the group, the demon girl licked her lips again as she saw me. Making a less than graceful exit from the conversation, she made a quick movement and suddenly appeared at my side, her left arm twining around my right arm. "So, *you're* the big strong man they call God King, hmm?"

Immediately, alarm bells went off in my head. *Danger! Danger! Red Alert! Warning!* "Y-yes, but just, uh, call me Hero, for short."

She licked her lips again as her eyes scanned my body up and down once again. Good lord, I'm not the greatest with the opposite sex, but it was *slightly obvious* what she wanted.

And then I happened to notice Cassiel staring over at us intently, blushing as the scantily clad demon lady rubbed herself all over me.

The demon girl winked over at Cassiel, something my infinite vision wanted badly to not have noticed but did anyway. "So, how do you feel about succubus girls, hmm? My name is Samantha, but for men I like, I have a secret succubi name reserved just for them."

I swallowed hard, as I could feel Cassiel's stare boring into me. I tried to gently pull away from Samantha but she wouldn't let me go. "Ah, that's great! You seem like a..." My infinite vision carefully noted her bulging chest and incredibly tiny amount of clothing. "...very sweet girl."

Cassiel quietly walked over to me and looped her arm inside mine. "Oh Samantha, it was... good getting to know you. We do need to head home you know, *Hero* has had a long day today." She put heavy emphasis on the word Hero, which reminded me that this was the name she had heard me using at first.

Samantha finally unhooked herself from me, her face looking all pouty. "Well, Mr. *Hero*, if you ever want to have a little fun, you just hop on by and give me a call, okay?" She blew a big kiss at me, and I felt Cassiel squeezing my arm very tightly. My face must have become an inferno of red. I was nigh close to teleporting out of there.

"Ah, yeah. N-nice meeting you, S-Samantha..."

She giggled as she pranced away. *Holy shit* she wears a tiny amount of clothes. Isn't that against military protocol or something?!

Cassiel stared straight ahead, wordlessly staring at a wall, as I could almost feel a psychic vision glaring daggers of ice at me. I might be interpreting the situation wrong. I hope I'm interpreting it wrong.

* * *

As we walked home later that night, I blushed. "Ah, I'll have to set up a bed for you when we get there. Just give me a minute and I'll carve out a spot in the house, okay?"

Cassiel, her arm still tightly locked in mine, shook her head slightly. "No... that won't be necessary. We can just... share."

I swallowed hard at her words. "Ah... I see."

I'm just... inept sometimes.

Part 142:

I woke up in the morning slowly. Very slowly. Usually I roll my eyes open and simply get up, but today I just laid there. A soft and warm girl was cuddled up beside me, her arm over my chest, and her soft feathery wings were wrapped under and over me.

It's going to be hard forgetting last night, not that I'd ever want to. It was my first time, as well as hers. While we were both awkward, we managed to work it out and figure out what we were doing as we went along.

A stupid thought enters my mind. *Can an angel get pregnant?* My first reaction is no, but... I'll have to, uh, ask an expert sometime. My cheeks are burning red just thinking about it.

Well, even if I don't ask, given time, I'll eventually figure it out.

My mental vision sees everything in the house. Even... the spot of blood where Phoebe died... What the hell is wrong with me...

I... my first time... in the same house as where she was murdered. Why did I do it? I pretended to ignore it last night... but I can't ignore it when it's always in my vision.

I close my eyes and focus on the spot where Phoebe's blood is at. Then I whisper a single word. " *Teleport.* "

In a single movement, my naked body is transferred over to where she's at. I listen closely, but Cassiel doesn't seem to notice me gone. I find myself reaching down and touching the red spot on the floor. *I failed her.* This... this may be the biggest regret of my life. Quietly, I whisper again. *Clean.* And the blood vanishes instantly... like it was never there.

I silently walk back into my bedroom, put on my regular clothes, and walk out towards Phoebe's house. Cassiel is still fast asleep. I don't want her here for this.

" *Shovel.* " I speak a word aloud, and it appears. I could do this the easy way... but I don't deserve the easy way. I have to do this the hard way.

After 20 or so minutes, I've dug out quite a hole in the ground. I'm not tired at all... but I can feel tears streaming down my face. *It's my fault.*

I aim my hand at the hole. " *Coffin.* "

A gold and silver coffin appears. The value of this would probably be equal to a few dozen million dollars in the world I came from... but for me, the coffin is garbage. This is the *least* I can do.

The next word is difficult for me to say, but I manage to say it anyway. "*Phoebe.*"

Her lifeless body appears in my arms. She's in... exactly the same condition I found her yesterday. Nothing decomposes or changes over time when it's in my storage void. *Nothing.*

I step into the hole, and place her body inside. I can't... help but cry. Tears won't stop coming as they drip onto her body. *I failed you.*

I step up and out of the hole, putting the lid on top of her coffin, as I halt for one final look at her face. She looks so... *sad.*

As I put the lid on the coffin, I step out of the way, and begin slowly shoveling dirt on top, as I seal up the hole. Once it's all back in place, there's a sizeable amount of ground lumped on top. That's fine. It's... fine.

I aim my hand at the top of the grave. " *Gravestone.*"

A blank gravestone appears, and I etch words into it by pressing down with my finger. I'm very strong now.

Here lies Phoebe, Closest friend of the God King.

Slain by one she called friend, she is with the angels now.

Birthdate: Unknown. Death: Unknown.

She was a close friend, and a pure hearted person. Rest in peace.

I stared at the gravestone in front of me. This is it. All this power... this is all I can do. *God King.* What a presumptuous title. What good is having the powers of a god... if I can't even save the life of my closest friend? Amelia... Hoarhiim... Phoebe... Adams... I've lost so many, and all their deaths were my own fault.

Amelia may not have been a good person, she was very evil, in fact... but I still can't hate her... not deep in my heart.

How many more will die because of my actions? How many more will die due to my inaction? I... can't let that happen. I must become more powerful. I must gain power over life and death. This is the only way I can be sure to prevent senseless deaths like this forever.

I have to become the *Creator.*

Part 143:

We were down in the basement of the castle once again, in the forge where my clones would previously have been summoning materials and such for the war effort. Without them around though, this area of the castle was now being used for other purposes.

The portal room is now staffed by an entire battalion, almost 500 troops, just in case of an invasion. The biggest benefit of having the battalion stationed there wasn't just protecting the motherland, as it were, but quick and easy reinforcement for all our bases. If one were attacked by the enemy, we'd instantly have 500 troops mobilized and ready to go.

Since I will no longer summon clones, I've come up with an incredible solution.

Cody and the Yellow team's top 5 members follow behind me, along with Cassiel, who never seems to leave my side. I approach the gate leading to one of the outpost worlds.

"What did you end up naming it?" I ask Cody.

He scratches his face and looks away. "Well, uh, you'll probably think this is stupid... but we just called it... Mining Planet Alpha."

I stare at him, my face is frozen in awe. *Mining Planet Alpha*? What kind of stupid fucking name is-

Never mind. "Alright. Better idea, we'll call it..." I pause as a list of a thousand names comes to mind, but I decide to settle for one that reminds me of home. "...Mars. We'll call this planet Mars. Any objections?"

Cody shrugs and he looks back at the others in his group. They all seem to think it's fine too. Perfect.

"Alright, so let me get this straight, we've dug inside the planet, and the only way in and out is through this exact portal, correct?"

Cody nods. "Yes, this was an important project by King Adams. He wanted to have the mining base be totally secured. There is literally no entrance into the base from the outside of the planet beyond teleporting or digging ten miles into it."

I nodded. "Absolutely perfect. That guy..." I waved off the thought. "Adams was a good man. Let's do this, then."

We entered the portal to 'Mars' and appeared inside the mining base. I was shellshocked to see that instead of being dark and dingy, choked with dust, or anything of the sort, we appeared in a perfectly white hangar area, with lots of men and women in uniforms moving around with

carts, hand-trucks, and many other such things, moving refined and unrefined ore and metal from one end of the station to the other.

The room was MASSIVE, stretching up over a hundred feet into the air before you would touch the ceiling, and the room itself was about the size of 6 football fields stacked to the sides vertically and horizontally.

Cody must have seen my gasping mouth because he stifled a guffaw. "N-no, God King, we didn't make this. Your clones did. And they did it in about an hour according to Adams' designs."

I paused. "Is the rest of the facility like this?"

"No, just the main room. He wanted there to be lots of possibilities for expansion."

I stared all around me at the grandeur of the room. Adams... you really outdid yourself. I wish you could be here to see what comes next.

I started walking to a back corner of the room where nobody was currently mulling around or occupying the space. "Cody, listen up. I will be leaving *you* in charge of humanity. I do not plan to come back for a... long time. Since I will not be leaving my clones behind, it's up to you to protect the future of our race. Therefore, I will be leaving you a... *gift*."

Cody's jaw hung open. "Y-you're leaving us? Alone?! I have some good soldiers, God King, but with all due respect, what could you possibly leave behind that would be better than clones?"

I ignored him and we kept walking. Finally, we arrived at the back corner. "Cody, in the world I come from, there's a particularly awful but simultaneously perfect saying for a situation like ours. It goes: *There's more than one way to skin a cat*. Awful, to be sure, but what it means is that where there's a will, there's a way. And I have a will, so I will find the way."

I aimed both of my hands at the back corner and concentrated deeply. I spent 5 minutes using the Crown to visualize exactly what I needed to do. I pored over every possible angle of the device as sweat began dripping down my head. Imagining every possible circuit, every piece of machinery... I finally called out the world.

" REPLICATOR!! "

In front of me, a device began taking shape. It was massive, going all the way up to the ceiling, the 'important' area being 50 feet wide by 50 feet deep. This was it, the ultimate machine.

I gasped finally, realizing I had been holding my breath as I strained to use the crown to create something I'd never invented in my life into reality.

Cody gazed up at the awe-inspiring machine. "By the gods... what in the name of hell is that?"

Part 144:

Ahh... this is awesome. I never got to live in the future, but now I am bringing the future to *me!*

While everyone else gasped and ooh'd and ahh'd, Samantha, the sneaky little *devil*, popped up alongside me and slipped her arm around mine again, even going so far as to clasp her hand inside mine.

"Oooh honey, you're so good with *words*, you're making me shiver with anticipation!"

I sighed.

Then Cassiel grabbed my other arm *because of course she did*. This is... well it's actually kind of great and yet awful. I've got things to *do*, ladies.

"Get your hands off him! He's- He's mine!" Cassiel said something that made me instantly blush. Shit, when did she get so daring?

Samantha giggled. "Aww, that's so cute. Angel's got her first c-r-u-s-h~!" Cassiel fumed at those words. "But you know, I'm not necessarily a one-guy-one-girl kind of gal, you know? I don't mind sharing~!"

Jesus Christ, the heavens need to protect me. I'm trying to do work and two girls are fighting over me. I seriously don't know whether to be delighted or annoyed.

While the two pressed their bodies against me, and begin to say all manner of embarrassing things, Cody cleared his throat. " *Ahem*, Samantha, that is not conduct becoming of a soldier."

Samantha turned around and glowered at him, sticking her tongue out. "Nyaah. I do what I want, I am my own woman you know."

I decided I'd had about enough of this. "Samantha, you're very lovely, but could we do this another time? This is important."

Samantha frowned as she slowly and very hesitantly pulled herself away. "Aww... well, I know you're just *shy* so I'll come visit you sometime, mkay?"

This girl... Cassiel, seeing the succubus had let go, she walked over to her and pulled her away. When they were out of earshot, they started speaking to each other, but I couldn't tell about what exactly. I could read their lips if I wanted to, but I decided against it. I don't have a death wish.

I raised my hands again and aimed them at the Replicator. " **Clone!** "

Unlike before, when I had tested with Adams, I was pretty sure that cloning machinery would be easy, and unsurprisingly, it was. I cloned the replicator three more times, for a total of 5 of them.

"Listen up, Cody. These replicators are insanely valuable. They can create any form of non-biological matter, so long as you have the blueprints for it, and enough energy for it. Unfortunately, energy is the biggest problem you will have. Fortunately, I'm here for that.

I aimed my mind at my own body again. "*Suit!*"

Around me, a spacesuit appeared. I wore this because... I had to go to the surface. I waved at Samantha and Cassiel. "I'll be right back."

Cassiel saw me in the strange suit, and I saw a look of concern pass over her face. But just as it came, it disappeared. And then I cast another spell.

"*Teleport!*"

Instantly, I was on the surface. The sun seemed close enough to give energy, but since the people of this planet are way deep inside it, I decided to... ahem... *increase the output*.

I aimed my hands up at the sun and concentrated deeply.

"**Enlarge!**"

Slowly, after a few minutes, the sun became 50% bigger, its size now massive compared to the sun on Earth. On top of that, the heat became quite intense. It felt like it was easily 200 degrees on the surface, extremely dangerous even for my powerful body.

I aimed my mental image a few hundred feet underground. "*Hollow!*"

And empty space appeared, about 20 feet in diameter and roughly the size of a small rounded apartment. "*Teleport!*"

I appeared inside the hollow spot, the space still quite cool as the heat hadn't yet gotten down this deep. Using my mental imaging, I started casting more spells.

"Panel!" A solar panel appeared, as I had imagined in my mind. "**Resist! Resist! Resist!**"

I made it heat resistant, to the point where heat wouldn't negatively affect it at all.

And then, for the next three hours, I cloned those panels. Over and over and over again. More than 25,000 times.

Energy for the replicator would soon be an issue of the past.

Part 145:

Using every fiber of my being, I finally finished summoning what my calculations told me were enough solar panels to power the replicators deep below the surface. After some adjustments to the planet's speed and some other things to make sure it didn't plummet into the sun, I then spent an hour wiring all the solar panels together and pumping the wiring down to the main base.

Finally, I teleported back down, my entire body drenched in sweat.

Everyone there jumped for joy when they saw me appear. I erupted out of the spacesuit, tearing it off and flinging it to the ground. My body and mind ached, but one great thing about my new powers is that my upper limit for thought and spiritual energy has greatly expanded, possibly by a factor of 50. I still had quite a lot of energy left over, and after some well earned sleep, I would have it all regenerated possibly by the next day.

"Cody... hah... it's done. The replicator is complete."

I showed him how they worked. Simply put, anything you put on the platform can be 'uploaded' as a blueprint, and then 'downloaded' as a whole new item that exactly copies the blueprint down to the individual molecule.

This would allow for rapid construction of a new set of weaponry.

"And now, Colonel Cody, we begin... phase 2..."

I aim my hands at the ground as a new set of blueprints crosses my mind. For 5 minutes, I concentrate as I once again pour my mind into various parts of the item.

Finally, I have it all completed.

" **Mecha!** "

In front of me, dissolving into view, a massive, hulking set of armor appears. The armor is extremely thick, the plates being nearly 12 inches of solid titanium. It's colored blood red and gold, the color of humanity's fight to survive. It has no actual weapons, but its defensive capabilities are unmatched.

This is no normal set of armor, this is the very first prototype *Mecha* suit of armor. A weapon to surpass Metal Gear, if you will. I laugh at my own stupid joke, but nobody else would get the humor so... never mind.

This suit enfolds around the user's body and auto-adjusts to their height and physical ability. It provides protection against anything, from claws, to bullets, to acids.

Cody and all the others, even regular techs in the room, pause to gaze in awe at this magnificent suit of armor. I've truly outdone myself.

"Colonel Cody. You will now be the new leader of humanity. This suit, the Mark I Demonslayer will be your personal suit. But this is not the gift I had promised to leave you. *This is.* "

Once again, I focus my mind as I imagine the exact technical details of how this will work. My mind connects bits and pieces of the circuitry and powerful pieces of the electronics. Finally, I will it to happen.

" *Vibroaxe!* "

A massive battleaxe appears in midair, then falls to the ground, smashing with tremendous force. It has energy that pulses on the blade, allowing it to slice through even thick steel armor with ease. About as close to a lightsaber as I'll ever get, I suppose.

"As the leader of humanity, you need to be a man intimidating enough to make the demons cower in fear when they hear of your approach. The Mark I Demonslayer, and the *Hellraiser* axe will make you a terrifying and intimidating opponent on the battlefield.

I then created a less advanced but still exceptionally powerful variant of the battle armor. "This is the Mark I Battle Armor Prime. Its fighting capabilities are still godlike compared to what we use today, but it's just weak enough that if the enemies ever manage to gain an edge in battle, the appearance of your suit will shred their confidence to pieces. These are my gifts for you, Colonel Cody."

Cody grinned so wide that happiness felt like it radiated from his body. " *Now* I understand, God King. You have truly outdone yourself. How can we possibly lose to the demon hordes now?"

I smiled, but then my smile faded. "Cody... have you ever wondered why it is that there are no advanced human worlds? Have you ever wondered why all the worlds we've found have been lacking when it comes to technology?"

Cody nodded. "Yes... the thought had crossed my mind."

I paused. I wasn't sure how to word this, but thanks to the abilities of the crown, I had a 90% confidence threshold.

"Cody. This will come as a shock to you but... I believe we have another enemy. One that is neither demon, nor human, nor angel, nor god. An enemy that is... *alien* in nature. I don't know who they are... but I know that if we should ever encounter them... as we are now... we are guaranteed to lose."

Cody stared at me, his own smile gone now. "What makes you so sure of this?"

I paused. "Because if humanity is truly on as many weird and strange worlds as we've found, but no trace of the technology that got them there exists anymore, yet the demons are not easily slaughtering and killing all of humanity... there must be another player in this war. I know not who, where, when, or why... but I know they *exist*. Do not grow overconfident with these weapons. Just as we grow too acquainted with them... they may be the death of us."

The room around us dulled, as everyone nearby was lost to their own thoughts.

Aliens.

Part 146:

My eyes are drooping, now that I've spent more than 8 hours summoning things all day, not to mention all the insane concentration and reliance on the Crown that I've been doing lately.

I sighed, as I drooped back into my easy chair. I'm back at home now, and I am... *tired*.

Cassiel walks in the door, having gone out to get some food. I told her it wasn't necessary, but she ignored me. She goes over to the wood-stove I had created many years ago, and starts making... eggs? And bacon? Silly woman, that's for breakfast... not that I can complain, as it's a hell of a lot better than... chi-... chiii-... chicken... ugh, the word makes me want to throw up, just thinking about it.

"So... we're going into the labyrinth and leaving this place behind then?" She speaks while her back and wings face me as she cooks.

"Yes. I've given humanity what it needs. They will at the least be able to hold their own. But finally, for now, I need to return to my original goals. I need to solve the mysteries of this accursed labyrinth."

She nods quietly. "I suppose so. Won't you miss... the people here?"

Will I? Of course. I'm not doing this because I hate humanity. I'm doing this because, in the end, I want to save them. Beyond them just being my species, after ten years, I've grown attached to this place. After ten years, I've made friends that will be with me for the rest of my life... even if they pass on.

"Yes. But I have to complete my goal. I traveled here in a device that allowed me to skip the passage of time instantly. I have no idea what happened during that time period, but whatever it was, it was serious. In fact, the most baffling thing to me is how my pod went from being on Earth to ending up in this maze that spans the dimensions. That couldn't have been accidental. Someone or... something... must have put me there." I gazed out the window at the darkening nighttime. This was... almost a normal reality. Living on this planet... why not just live here forever? I'm immortal now, I can train, get stronger, live a good life...

But it would be empty. It would be like playing an hour of a fantastic videogame and then deciding to spend the next 99 in a safe village. Life is risk, and you need risk to call yourself alive.

* * *

After she had finished the, err, bacon and eggs, we sat down to eat a dinner before bed. *Bed.* My thoughts drifted back to last night. I'm dog tired but, I mean, why not, right? I guess I could just, uh, reinvigorate myself temporarily or something.

I do however genuinely need to sleep in order to recover my spiritual and thought energy. For some reason, if I don't enter REM sleep, my body will not refuel itself naturally. Naps don't do it, and I can't cheat by casting a spell to give myself more thought energy. But why sleep? Why is sleep the only way I can recover it?

As I eat, I glance up and notice that Cassiel is finished, and she's leaning on her hand, staring at me. She's very beautiful, and staring her right in the face always catches me a little off guard.

"W-what is it? Do I have something on my face?" Hell yeah, just try the simple approach.

Cassiel turned away and stared at the floor. "Um, actually, I had a request to make of you, but I didn't... know how to ask..."

I almost choked on my food. *Oh boy, here it comes.*

She blushed a little as she looked back at me. "Can... you, um... you and I... can we..."

I could almost feel the tips of my ears turning red. Yeah? Yeah?! What are the two of us going to do?!

"...Can you train me to be a strong fighter?"

* * *

I feel fucking foolish. Ah, that's what she was getting at. My mind was in the gutter. "Yeah, what do you want to learn?"

"Well, I may be just a boring old reborn human, but I do possess angelic powers. Maybe you could teach me how to be useful in battle. It'd be a shame if we went into the labyrinth together and you did all the fighting... I'd hate to leave it all to you... even if you can easily handle it, I guess."

I nodded slowly. "Yes, but... you know, what might be more useful... offensively, you're not going to be very strong, or fast, but I suppose you'd make for a great support unit. You could heal me if I was hurt, maybe buff me when needed, cast status ailments on the enemy, etc."

She looked confused. "Status ailments? What are those?"

I shrugged. "It's like uh, putting them to sleep, blinding them, stuff like that."

Cassiel nodded. "Okay! That sounds better than nothing! Are we going to start soon then?"

I glanced at the analog clock on the wall. This world has a 36 hour time cycle, but we're practically at midnight right now... "Ah, certainly not tonight. Perhaps tomorrow."

She nodded, and then blushed again. "Oh, that reminds me... I'm expecting a guest here, pretty soon."

Huh? A guest? At this time of the night? I expanded my vision to encompass multiple city blocks. Everyone was already asleep, except... a couple blocks away... someone was coming.

It was Samantha.

"I invited Samantha over, after, she and I, eh, we had a little chat! Just a harmless little chat! No big deal, really!"

I had an odd feeling in my stomach. "Cassiel, what's going on? Wh-what did you two talk about?"

She blushed again. She seems to do that a lot. "About the, ah, status of our relationship... I mean, I'm n-not a little girl you know! I'm a mature, responsible woman, I-I don't get jealous like a child would or anything!"

She's stuttering. And talking very fast. I either like where this conversation is going a *whole lot* or *not at all*. I haven't decided yet.

While thinking those thoughts, Samantha arrived and knocked on the door. After coming in, she smiled at me with a twinkle in her eye. "I'm guessing Cassiel explained the situation then? I'll be joining you on your trip in the labyrinth!"

She hopped over a little bit closer and whispered in my ear. " *And tonight as well~!* "

I guess I'm not actually going to get much sleep tonight.

Part 147:

It's morning now. I wake up and maybe 25% of my energy has refilled, if that. I... don't remember actually falling asleep last night. Merciful Christ, I may be a God-King now, but I may need my own hero to save me after last night.

My eyes flutter open and the bright sunlight makes me want to close them again. Samantha is sleeping on top of me, while Cassiel is on my right side, wrapped all around and over me, as she usually is.

An interesting predicament, to be sure. Since I took the crown off and it's on the table a few feet away, it won't be able to help me escape this situation, though I'm not so sure I *want* to escape. Eventually, I just cast "Sleep" on Cassiel and Samantha both, and I get up, placing them both down in the bed behind me. They'll be out for another 3 or 4 hours more, according to the strength of the spell I used.

Today is an important day. I will be re-entering the labyrinth and I have to make sure Hero City is ready to go. If I leave it behind without making sure things are going smoothly, I could come back and find the entire place destroyed. I can't have that.

While those two sleep, I have some work to do.

I have been thinking about my battle with Hope. He silenced me, using my own wordsmithing. I may have been able to win without wordsmithing, if only just because my body is extremely powerful now, but it stands to reason that being silenced is always going to be a pretty big problem.

So it's simple, I need a way to prevent myself from being silenced. I need something that protects me from negative status effects. Not just silence, even. I need a way to protect myself against other effects, like sleep, or paralysis.

I go outside and sit in the warm morning sun. It's nice out here... it really is. I aim my hand at myself. " *Reflect*. "

I feel a faint aura surround me. What will this reflect though? I tried to visualize status debuffs, but that could mean anything. Hmm. " *Modify. Enemy*. "

I don't know if 'modify' works, but *something* seems to have changed. If I'm lucky, maybe I can think of ways to modify long term buffs and debuffs with it... In any case, I won't know until I fight in a battle, but it will hopefully prove to be useful.

And now I find myself thinking about Cassiel's request. She wants to be useful in battle, was it? I can't say I have a problem with that. She might feel weak and vulnerable if all she is, is a support character. Maybe I can buff her somehow.

* * *

Aha! It's so obvious. I couldn't do it before, but I can now! I reach my hand out once again.

" *Armor.* "

A set of pure white female armor appears in front of my hand. *Valkyrie armor*, to be specific. I can't think of anything more appropriate for her. She even has the pure white angelic wings that lore used to speak of. I'd like to make some armor for Samantha, but I'm not sure if she would... um... wear it... And in any case, with armor, one also needs a weapon. I've got that covered too.

" *Vibrosword.* "

A weapon appears, a slender and thin sword, one with energy that can be activated on the blade, allowing one to cut through nearly anything by making the blade vibrate at a specific frequency. Not exactly a lightsaber, but close enough.

" *Sharpen! Sharpen! Sharpen! Strengthen!* "

The sword is insanely sharp now. Lightly touching it to anything will cause said thing to split nearly instantly. I test this on one of my fingers, very gently touching my finger against the sword. My fingers splits and starts bleeding all over the place.

Hm... I still only have a normal human's vitality when it comes to healing wounds. Better fix that.

" **Regeneration! Regeneration! Regeneration!** "

I look down and my finger wound is healed. Ohohoho... I touch my finger to the sword again, it splits open, and the moment I pull it away, it heals itself in a flash. *Interesting.* I should have done this sooner.

I'm beginning to wonder what else I can do with my powers. I've never really experimented in the last ten years, but I need to start.

Hey, maybe I can make a gun now. I failed in the past, but I wasn't smart back then.

I aim my hand at the ground, and mentally picture a familiar weapon from an old TV show I remember. " *Blaster.* "

A small, handheld blaster forms after a few minutes of my mind concentrating on the mechanical details. This looks very similar to Han Solo's weapon, hehe. I'm kind of excited now.

I raise my hand up and cast another spell. " *Target*. " A target appears for me to test the blaster on.

When I aim it at the target, no sounds are emitted, no bolt of light shoots out, but the instant I press the trigger, the target fucking *explodes*. Holy shit!

Now that I think about it, that makes sense. Those old movies always showed beams of light that seemed to shoot more slowly than bullets. I mean, when you fire a bullet, you never see it travel at all. Why would something traveling the speed of light somehow be *visible*?...This may be a really potent weapon.

In fact, I need to get one of these to Colonel Cody before I leave. Ah... *Colonel* Cody. I... need to rectify that. To be honest, I don't think he's as good of a leader as Adams was, but since Adams is dead now... it can't be helped. We need a new king, and I will have to make sure that the king is announced properly this time.

Well then, I was going to let the girls sleep, but they might as well wake up. It's been a couple hours and they've gotten more sleep than I did. We need to start and finish the preparations today, and be gone by tonight.

I just have this feeling that I need to leave *soon*. I can't explain it with words.

Part 148:

I find myself walking towards the castle, with an angel girl on my right arm, and a demon girl on my left. Not going to lie, this does feel pretty badass. They keep looking at each other and winking, like they have some secret they're hiding from me. I feel like whatever the secret is, I'm going to find out soon enough.

Cassiel was excited to get her new armor, and, as I expected, Samantha got a little bit jealous that *she* didn't get anything. However, to her delight, I'd already made her some sexy, albeit functionally useless, new armor. It's really just more of... um... a leather thong and skirt along with something to cover up her knockers, and it really doesn't hide much beyond that... but it does come with a cool electro-whip! I'm actually kind of terrified to see how she'll use it on demons in the labyrinth, given her sadistic and playful side.

Not to mention how she might use it on *me*... that's a story for another day.

As we approach the castle, I'm getting looks of jealousy and admiration from many manner of folks, all of them shooting shocked expressions and glares my way. I don't really like the attention, but soon, I won't have to worry about it.

We arrive in the armory again, and the girls mercifully let go of my arms. Do they think I'm going to flee? Who would?

Cody is there again. "God King! Err, Hero? Whatever you prefer. Anyway, we've started using the Replicator, and it is giving us fantastic results!"

I grin gleefully. "I can't wait to see it! Show me what you've been up to."

He does. I'm flabbergasted. The entire hangar on Mars has over 250 of those suits made. He must have been replicating them nonstop since yesterday.

Two cadets are in the suits, having a mock battle in the center of the room. The speed of the suits is terrible, but the strength is colossal. Every time they pound their fists against each other, it makes the sound of a small explosion.

Cody stares intently at the battle. "As strong as they are, and as sure as I am they they would crush most low level demons, I still feel that the suits have a lot of vulnerabilities in the combat department that any smart enemy would seize on quickly."

I nod. "You're right. They are actually terrible close combat suits, they're meant for ranged warfare."

I hold up the blaster and he stares at it quizzically. "What's this?"

"This is what will make the suits go from dangerous to nearly unstoppable. It's called a blaster, and I'm going to make a variant just for them."

I aim my hand at an empty space in the hangar, make a target, and fire at it to show my point. The explosion convinces him instantly. "I can't wait!"

Ten minutes later, it sits in front of me. A massive blaster that fires semi-automatically. If you pull the trigger, the enemy dies. I even found a way to make it recharge by drawing from the user's spiritual energy pool. Since humans tend to never use their energy, this makes it have a lot more ammunition than a regular gun, while not having to lug around said ammunition.

The gun was actually so big and bulky that I found it difficult to carry, but once I got inside a Mechasuit, it was a piece of cake.

Cody and his team grinned widely as they saw the power of the blaster. "This is almost making it too easy, isn't it, Hero?"

I shrug. "It's only as easy as you want it to be."

And before I leave today, there's just one more matter to take care of.

Part 149: Coronation

After examining the new weapons and verifying that the Replicator is working, we all go out and have a nice final meal in the Great Hall. This will likely be the last time I see other people for a long time, as I'm going into the labyrinth and don't intend to come out for a long time.

Cody treats us to a fine, lavish meal, all freshly farmed from a world used almost entirely for raising cattle that he had liberated a few years ago. He calls it "Food World Alpha" which drives me insane, but oh well! It's pretty clear that I'm the only human with any ability to name things accurately.

As we eat, I find myself thinking about other things again. After I crown Cody as king, I have to leave. While it would honestly be more useful to simply leave the two girls behind, I don't want to see them crying or anything else like that, plus I've grown attached to Cassiel. Samantha, well, I'm sure she'd be fine, but Cody has spoken to me about her abilities. She may actually be extremely useful in the labyrinth.

I turn to Cody and silently beckon for him to follow me. We both get up from the table and leave the room. I feel eyes on us, but nobody gets up to follow. Good.

We arrive in a quiet room around the corner, and I close the door. " *Muffle*."

I cast muffling spells at all four walls and doors, just in case. Cody looks concerned, but that will be cleared up soon enough.

"Colonel Cody... listen, I have something to tell you. It's about your coronation. You need to be aware... when I was speaking with Adams, or his clone, or whichever one it was... it wasn't just him and Hope that plotted against me. There were several nobles that were at the table when I was knocked out. I knew very few of them. And I wasn't paying attention while I was there so I had forgotten who the ones I knew were."

Cody nodded. "Alright. That is about as I suspected."

I paused. "You knew?"

He shrugged as he leaned back in his chair. "Yes. A few of them approached me within what I suspect was a few hours of the incident. They wanted my help keeping quiet about a certain incident. At the time, I didn't know what they were talking about, but after your return, I pieced it together."

He glanced away and smiled thinly. "And with a bit of... coercion... I managed to dig up the names of hopefully all the conspirators."

I frowned. "Coercion?"

He grinned. "You know... torture."

I blanched. "Ah, yeah, of course. Well, I hope you didn't take it too far."

"Nah, don't worry about them. I made their deaths quick and painless." He waved his hand at me. "Treason is a capital crime, you know. Especially when it goes against the best interests of our entire species."

Well... I can't say he's wrong. It's not something Adams would have done but... well, Adams was murdered so... maybe his way wasn't always the right way.

"You did what you had to. A leader has to make tough choices." Yeah, that made sense. I'll leave it at that.

Cody stood up. "Is that it then? Anything else to say before you head off?"

I paused. Many things immediately came to mind. However, only one seemed to matter.

"*King* Cody. For the good of humanity... stay safe... and good luck."

* * *

The ceremony, as hastily thrown together as it was... was marvelous. I decided to give Cody an official Crown, and the duplicate crown of Solomon, found in Adams' belongings, was a perfect match.

I actually added some jewels and gems just to make it look a bit more kingly. Unnecessary, but I liked it!

Afterwards, I went home with my ladies and we packed up some stuff. Hoarhiim's orb has been safely in my storage void for a while now. I might as well just keep him there forever, until I can find something out.

His orb is still warm. After ten years, there hasn't been a sign of life in it, but I still feel hope every time I touch it. I won't let my first friend die so easily. *I refuse.*

Just as we're about to leave, Samantha grabs me. "Hey, before we head out, why not have a little fun first? This'll be the last time we get to enjoy a nice warm bed for a long while, don't you think?"

I sigh as Cassiel nods enthusiastically. It's not like I'm mad or anything.

Part 150: Extermination

"Heh, Tvoorik, isn't this the best?" I grin as I look over at my bestest buddy. He doesn't return the smile.

"Quiet down. We're still just guards, you know. We're just waiting to be minced into pieces by the filthy meatbags."

I waved him off. "Oh come on, you're always such a fuddy-duddy. The humans have been losing badly for weeks! Their Hero deserted them and without his clones around, the Grez are mopping up!"

Tvoorik shook his head. "Clearly three evolutions in a row hasn't done you any favors in the brain department. Listen, stupid, that's what *they* want you to think."

I rolled my eyes. Fuck's sake, not this again.

Tvoorik continued. "Ylvusk, listen, I've got it all figured out. Now that we're shadow-walkers, the commanders are going to start issuing dangerous orders to us. They know we know that they know we know too much, you copy? So they're going to start ordering us to infiltrate the enemy's base or some crazy shit like that. Once we do, BAM! We get murdered and nobody ever finds out what we know."

"For crying out loud! I swear, you'll believe any conspiracy theory. What's next, the demons are supplying the humans with top secret weaponry to destabilize the labyrinth so they can remove more of our demonic freedoms?"

Tvoorik grinned and nodded intently. "Now you're beginning to understand."

I slapped my face into my palm. This moron...

Tvoorik stiffened suddenly. "Quiet... I *feel* something."

I slowly moved my face away from my hand and waited. I could feel something too. A rumbling, deep in the Earth. Steadily growing more and more noticeable. Soon, in the distance, I could hear the sound of a slow but steady rumbling, and it was coming this way.

"Tvoorik, warn the guards. Gather the orcs."

He and I quickly activated our invisibility abilities, blending into the shadows. We ran back the short distance to the others. "Something's approaching, and whatever it is, I don't think it's friendly." Tvoorik whispered to the orc commander. However, if it really was those filthy humans, we had a surprise in store for them.

We have a Duke here. The Duke of Reptiles, to be exact. His Evilness, Agares.

* * *

He appeared as an old man, but rode atop his crocodile, which he aptly named Crocomire. "I can sense them coming. These humans are different from the ones we've fought before. Be on the alert, they may have... evolved new weapons..."

Agares' eyes narrowed as he eyeballed the corridor up ahead. The noise was unmistakable now. It was the sound of slow moving but very heavy and loud footsteps. He remembered something now, an old tale Satan had told him about humans who were given room to expand, and the disastrous consequences for angelkind, as well as demonkind.

We're not the monsters. Humanity is. Parasites that destroy all other life. Pure evil.

Agares had never forgotten Satan's words. And now, he realized those words were seconds away from being proven true.

* * *

I stared in awe from the shadows, along with Tvoorik. A massive series of metallic monsters appeared from around the bend. They had bright glowing eyes that shot out beams of light, illuminating all they gazed upon. Their forms were decidedly humanoid, though massive. They all stood at least 7 feet tall. While slow... they looked tough. Really tough.

I spoke to Tvoorik with telepathy. *We won't be of any use here. Let's wait until the action starts, then split.*

Tvoorik carefully nodded, his body and mine invisible unless we moved. As shadow-walkers, stealth is our most important ability. Thanks to the intel we gave to Diablo (Against Tvoorik's judgement), we were gifted with forced evolutions as a reward for our... 'bravery'. I mean, we hid and cowered in fear, but if they wanted to give us evolutions, I was not going to refuse!

Suddenly, just as the clankers came into view, I gasped audibly as explosions lit up the corridor. I couldn't tell what was happening, but before the orcs could even charge into battle, they were being felled left and right!

"Satan the Devil! We need to get the heaven out of here!" I grabbed Tvoorik and we split, as the screams of agony filled the corridor.

"Retreat!" Agares yelled at the top of his lungs. It hadn't been even a minute yet, and he was ordering the retreat?! What the heaven?! What did these humans do to get so strong?!

As we ran Tvoorik turned towards me, with a knowing grin. " *What did I tell you?* It starts from the top."

That idiot.

Part 151:

Agares grimaced as he delivered the news, ready for a thrashing from Diablo.

It never came. Diablo instead turned and vacantly stared out the window of the conference room. The other dukes, kings, and lords stared down at the table as they pondered this.

"Massive battle suits. Why didn't Umi warn us? Isn't that what an Oracle is supposed to do?" Bael, as always, was the first one to break the silence. He was a quick thinker, in the way that he always wanted to get the thinking done as quickly as possible so he didn't have to do any more thinking than necessary.

President Ose shrugged. "Umi has been... quiet." She heaved a sigh. *That's an understatement of the year. I haven't heard anything from her in a large number of ticks.*

Diablo's eyes unclouded as he shook his head. He also sighed. "This is growing... tiresome. Many of you were not there for the very beginning of humanity's development... but I was. Along with Satan himself and a few others still alive today, we witnessed a great many things. We learned the true horrors of war."

Diablo stared down at the table, a hint of sorrow almost visible in his eyes. "Demons like Ose and the others were born long after we had constructed the labyrinth. I mean no offense, but you don't know why we live the way we do. It is a necessity. We thought we could eradicate the humans once we had dealt with the angels, but that proved to be untrue."

Bael eyeballed Diablo intently. "Are humans really that dangerous, yet so important for our survival?"

Diablo nodded grimly. "Yes. A few hundred thousand years before the actual plans for the labyrinth were created... demonkind could have gone extinct. We require the presence of humans for a variety of small yet important reasons, just as angels needed humans to give them thought energy... but humans neither need the two of us, nor want us."

Barbatos felt a wave of nausea pass over his face. "Hngh. You must be speaking of the Energy Wars. I've tried to forget those dark days. The terror of what happens when humanity becomes an unstoppable force. The fear I felt every day when we heard the approach of their weaponry."

Diablo rested his chin on his hands. "It's happening again. Only this time, the speed is accelerated, unprecedented, even. Those suits Agares spoke of, they sound like primitive, yet brutally effective versions of the Juggernauts. Not to mention the weapons he explained. Clearly

they're using some form of laser technology. That's highly advanced. Only the Wordsmith could take them from the medieval age to the spiritual age, in a manner of weeks."

Mephisto paused. "Forgive me for interrupting, but as I am young and know not of what you speak, what are the... 'Juggerknots'?"

Diablo coughed a little and his voice rasped. "Ah... it's not polite to generally bring them up among the veterans of the Energy Wars. They were brutally efficient, fast, powerful killing machines. It would seem the ones you witnessed required human pilots. The ones I know of were actually drones, piloted remotely by humans or by an Artificial Intelligence. I won't bother explaining what that last one is, you wouldn't understand it."

Mephisto shrugged as he sat back in his seat. "What you are basically saying, is that even if you destroyed those 'Juggerknots', you wouldn't even kill a human inside?"

Diablo grimaced. "Precisely."

"We lost millions of demons. Billions, even. All those centuries we spent preparing for the extermination of the angels, and all that breeding and evolving was pointless in the face of humanity." Barbatos almost appeared as if he had tears in his eyes. "What you younglings don't know is that all surviving demons, especially those like Diablo and I, who were not only survivors of the Energy Wars, but born in the First Age of demonkind... we only pretend to mock humans."

Diablo slumped back in his seat. "No... they deserve mockery. Look at what they've become for the last few millions of years. Cattle for the River. They deserved mockery. But Barbatos speaks the truth. He is the oldest living demon among our kind. We do fear the humans. We need them, but we wish we didn't."

Mephisto leaned forward in his seat. "So, Diablo, if you don't mind me asking... if humans were as unstoppable as you say... how the heavens did we manage to ever win? How could we have possibly come back from an onslaught like the one you speak of?"

Barbatos spoke inside, cackling as he pounded the table with his fist. "Gwaaahahaha! HOW indeed? That's easy, we made a new ally! At the cost of our integrity, we abandoned principles we had held since the first age and made allies among non demons! Gaahahaha!"

His laughter was not genuine. It was insane laughter, tinged with regret.

Diablo swallowed hard. "If only the *Volgrim* were a laughing matter."

Part 152:

Zeus sat atop the Throne of Heaven. Having consumed his father's colossal hoard of spiritual energy, he now stood at the same height Kronos once had, towering over all other beings. He wondered to himself quietly if this would become a tradition. Should one of his sons or another usurper attempt to take the throne, would they also consume his power and increase in size? Possibly, though only if they were a Titan as well.

He was worried, though. He had heard of Gabriel, the mightiest archangel, who had ascended to the Cosmos class. This one was a particularly loyal servant of Kronos. He was away on a mission but would be arriving back very soon, according to scouts.

How should I deal with him? Zeus thought to himself. *My father must have created Gabriel's current power and loyalty as a way to guarantee his seat on the throne. As long as no-one else dared to attack Kronos for fear of facing not just him but his loyal Cosmos-class archangel, his position as King of Gods would be assured.*

My father was foolish. He let his most powerful guard leave on a mission for an entire week, leaving himself vulnerable. Perhaps he didn't realize there was anyone mighty enough to dethrone him. Perhaps he was arrogant. It would explain why he casually toyed with my son's armies, allowing the enemy a victory. His desire to mock me and humiliate my son are just one of the many signs that he was an arrogant ruler who cared little for his people.

Zeus fumed silently. Suddenly, from the portal from Mount Sinai to Heaven, a massive spiritual energy source appeared. Zeus stiffened. *Gabriel. He's back sooner than I expected.*

Gabriel flew up towards the throne, from the exit point of the portal. He arrived in a flash, his small form enlarging as he was in more open airspace. He always had to shrink to pass through the portal, as did the rest of the larger angels and gods.

Gabriel landed smoothly and silently in front of Zeus. "What is this treachery? Why are you sitting atop the throne of the gods?"

Gabriel swept his gaze around, as others in the Great Hall silently averted their eyes.

"Gabriel... you are not the one who should be asking questions here. I am." I stared up at his form, which dwarfed me in size, even more so than my father's had when I was the size of a normal god. He must have been 100 times my size. We're lucky there is no roof for the throne building of the Gods, otherwise we'd never be able to build one big enough to contain this monster.

Gabriel leaned down, bringing his head frighteningly close to Zeus. His head was an order of magnitude bigger than Zeus' entire body, it made him feel incredibly tiny. "Oh? You have something to ask of me? Go right ahead."

Zeus kept his temper under control. He was not nearly so sure he could defeat Gabriel in combat. It's not that Gabriel was more powerful or a better fighter than Kronos, it's that Kronos was overconfident. Humble fighters never took big risks, and a big risk is what let Zeus be in the position he was in now.

"Why did you interfere in the battle between my son and his men, allowing them to be overcome and slain by the demonic hordes? Why did you refuse to aid them as well, not using that incredible magic of yours to wipe out the enemy as you had done twice before?" Zeus did not back down. To show fear would be to show weakness, and he was not a weak god.

Gabriel lifted himself up to his full height, then shrunk himself down to a bit bigger than Zeus' height. Zeus quietly breathed a sigh of relief. "So that's what this is about? I have my reasons. I do what I must to ensure the survival of our people." Gabriel deflected, evading the question.

Zeus glared at him. "You had better have some mighty good reasons. As of today, I am the new King of the Gods. I defeated Kronos, my father, in fair combat in front of thousands of spectators. With my authority as King, I will now order a trial to examine your motives for interfering with the Third Holy Battle on Earth. Your trial will be governed by a fair split of archangels, gods, and normal angels, as well as myself."

Gabriel frowned. "That seems harsh, but if that's what it takes, I will warn you of one thing: The knowledge of why I did what I did may end up destroying our kind if it leaks to the demons. Are you sure you want to continue?"

Zeus smiled. "Yes. I'm absolutely sure."

Gabriel nodded and bowed. "Very well. However, do not say that I did not warn you. We have spies among our people. Your actions may condemn us to inadvertent mass suicide. I apologize in advance for anything that may happen as a result of this trial."

Zeus mentally rolled his eyes, though he stifled the physical reaction. *So full of drama. He will do anything to protect his beloved dead king. I need to get rid of him before he becomes a threat to my new order.*

"Begone then, and return in one Earth week's time. We will begin the trial then."

Part 153: Imprisoned

I knew it would end up like this. The trial was a farce. Zeus had no intention of letting me speak, he only intended to either shame me into submission, or imprison me to consolidate his power.

Now I'm locked here, in an infinite dimension he specifically created to hold me. Naturally, I require no sustenance to keep myself alive, but surrounded by nothing but white, and a single platform for sitting on... I sit here, treated as if I had killed the king of the gods in his sleep with my own hands.

Every so often, I am allowed a single visitor. Naturally, as an angel, I lack offspring. Angels cannot reproduce, so I have no daughter or son. However, one of the other archangels, my brother Raphael, comes to visit me on occasion.

Today is such a day. I've been imprisoned for 15 rotations of the Earth, and he came, as he said he would. He tends to come every three rotations on the dot.

Raphael walked over, his thin and frail looking body belying his intelligence. "Gabriel, you still seem to be looking well as always."

"As well as I could ever hope to be, given these troublesome circumstances."

Raphael sat next to me, on the small elevated platform. It was essentially a bench, and since angels require neither food nor water nor sleep, I simply sat here and thought a lot, recently. There was no point flaunting my cosmic power, so I had simply shrunk myself to normal angelic size, not that Raphael was ever intimidated by my size. Nothing seemed to bother him.

Raphael stroked his chin as he spoke. "Many things have happened. Zeus has begun an aggressive war against the demons. With the help of humanity and Hercules' Knights, we're crushing them quite easily."

I nodded. "It was to be expected. We could have won the war at any point that we wanted."

Raphael glanced over at me for a split second before slowly looking away. "During the trial, you would not explain your motivations for betraying Hercules, as well as your people. Why were you and Kronos conspiring against your own people? Why do you wish to not win this war?"

I hesitated. I... trust Raphael. He is a good friend. He and I were created nearly at the same time. The Creator was a powerful being and gave both of us our own attributes. Raphael was

given wisdom, myself Might, Michael was given Divinity, Uriel was given Justice, and so on. The archangels were given many different things, but it was Raphael I trusted the most.

Strangely, Kronos had figured out so many things about angels and demons. He had figured out that we have to keep the war going, or humanity would turn on us. He had figured out that crushing the demons, an easily accomplished task, was the worst possible thing we could do.

"Raphael, before his death, Kronos and I had a long discussion..."

Raphael listened quietly as I explained the situation between the gods, angels, humans, and demons to him.

* * *

"I see. I had always suspected something like that was the case." Raphael nodded quietly, as he once again stroked his chin. "I was able to piece most of it together since the beginning, but I did not know that he was deliberately stoking the flames of war for our people's sake. Then... that means that Zeus is going to potentially be the death of us."

I stared ahead. "Yes. I no longer can stop him, due to my imprisonment. Perhaps I should have challenged him to a duel, then this may have-"

Before I could finish, Raphael raised a hand to interrupt me. "No! I sense a more important destiny for you. Fighting a foolish god is not why you were created, nor I. I believe that Zeus may listen to my counsel... perhaps I can convince him of the dangers without slipping the secrets to him."

I quickly glance over at Raphael. "Beware. Men and gods of hot tempers are ones with loose tongues. If he were to let it slip, it would put all of our people in grave danger."

Raphael stood up slowly. "I am aware of the risks. Despite what some may say, I do not consider myself the wisest being alive. I am simply as wise as I can possibly hope to be given my limited knowledge of the universe. There is much for me to learn, as well as you."

He started to walk towards the portal, holding up his hand. As he approached, the portal cleared up, allowing passage to Heaven.

"Thank you for listening to me, and giving me counsel, brother. May we both find a way to solve this problem without violence." I waved at him as he was about to leave.

"No, thank *you*, Gabriel. My wisdom and knowledge is dependent on others. I will treasure what you have told me and hold it close to my heart. Farewell."

Raphael let a small smile slip as he stepped through the portal, and it fogged up behind him.

I am alone once again. I must leave it to my brother now... only he can save our people.

Part 154:

Satan stared darkly at the report. His generals indicated various positions of troops and slowly managed to say what was on their mind.

We're being crushed.

Satan glared as the generals gave him a stunning number: 60%. That's how many of the demonic legion's warrior demons had been slain.

In just one month, more than half of their fighting force was eradicated from existence. The enemy didn't even use that Cosmic Class Angel, Gabriel anymore. Not that it mattered.

"If they had this kind of ability to crush us all along, why didn't they do it sooner?" Diablo, the second lord of the demons, stared at the mess in front of him. "There were times we were winning, and times we were losing, but even back when there were only a few evolutions, we never lost like this."

"It's that damned Hercules! He's impossible to beat!" Bael pounded the table with his fist. "His troops cannot be even touched as long as he leads them! The angels could be taken care of, individually we outnumber them ten to one, but those damned humans are like vermin, coming out of the woodwork faster than we can kill them! Our forces totaled almost a hundred million only months ago, now we're down to forty million!" As a general on the frontlines, Bael had seen many of his minions die to the Hercules-led knight legion.

Hmm.

Satan thought quietly to himself. "We still have the location of their home base. What if we were to strike at the angels directly?"

Lucifer, the third in command, scowled. "It's pointless. Their gods are incredibly powerful, though reclusive. If we could kill most of the angels, we'd have the advantage in future skirmishes to be sure but... if Gabriel makes an appearance, as he likely will, we will lose decisively."

The mood at the table worsened. *No options are left but to hide like rats.* That is what all at the War Table thought to themselves, even Satan.

However, Satan had an idea cross his mind. "So what you are saying is that as we are now, even the strongest demons at this table cannot compare to the gods that hide inside Mount Sinai?"

Lucifer slowly nodded. "Yes, my liege. What are you getting at?"

Satan silenced himself. He couldn't speak of what was on his mind. It was his closest guarded secret. After a few seconds, he went on a different path. "It's simple, then. If we can increase our fighting power to be above the angels and the gods, we can decisively crush them."

Bael spoke now, though more slowly than he usually would. "My lord, that is certainly... a fantastic idea but... that seems rather hard to do in such a short time."

Satan raised his hand and silenced him. "No, I have a way, though it will only work for me. I have a friend I must speak to, and I will be back before the morning comes. Stay here and strategize to cut our losses to a minimum. *I have work to do.* "

Satan quickly rose from his sitting position at the table and walked away towards the exit of the demonic mountain base.

Lucifer, the dark-walker, watched quietly as his master left.

* * *

Satan moved quickly, using his highly evolved body and its speed to rapidly leap forward in great bounds towards his destination, a small deserted human village 50 miles to the north. Crossing that long distance in a matter of hours, he arrived at the mountainside he remembered from his imp days, many years ago.

Glancing around to make sure no other life forms were in the area, he pushed aside a pile of rocks, quietly sealing them up behind himself as he entered a narrow tunnel that led deep into the mountainside. It was impossible to spot, unless you stumbled into it by chance, or happened to know exactly where to look. But Satan knew well... this was the key to his power.

After many minutes climbing downwards, he arrived at a familiar pathway, one he had mined out himself as a young imp. It just barely fit his massive form as he crawled on his stomach to get inside. At the end of this tiny pathway, the hole opened up.

Suddenly, he was in a massive, pitch black cavern. As he exited the hole, miles underground, he spoke aloud.

"Great Leviathan, master of all Darkness, your loyal servant has arrived once more." He got on his knees and bowed deeply.

" Hmm? Ahh, if it isn't Satan. So kind of you to have not... *forgotten me.* "

A massive dark dragon, the size of a small skyscraper, spoke to him. His body was pitch black, as were his eyes. Black flames were burning on his body, and in the darkness, he was invisible to all who gazed upon him.

But not to Satan. He had granted Satan favor as a young imp.

"I would never forget the one who gave my people their power, oh mighty one! I have come once more, to ask another favor, for but a trifle of your power."

The black eyes slowly burned themselves into a deep demonic crimson. " **Always asking favors, and never granting my one request... is this task too impossible for one as lowly as you?** "

Satan grimaced as he bowed in front of the black dragon. "No, my master, I only have one goal as I always have... to free you from this prison."

Part 155:

Lucifer watched from his vantage point half a mile away, in the shadow of a rock, as his master Satan shoved aside some debris, entered a hole and then covered it back up.

I wonder what he's hiding that he takes such great care to not be discovered. Lucifer thought quietly to himself, as he stayed unmoving for nearly two hours.

Finally, in the dead of night, there was a rumbling noise as Satan pushed aside the rubble and crawled out of the hole, carefully covering it up. However, something incredible caught Lucifer's eye. *Satan looked like he had evolved in the time he was inside the hole.* In fact, he didn't just evolve, power flowed off of him like he had evolved a dozen times.

Satan covered up the hole and dusted himself off, while quickly glancing around for anyone that might spot him. He didn't seem to spot Lucifer, which was expected, given Lucifer was the greatest dark-walker among the demons.

In a flash, Satan darted away, once again bounding tirelessly across the landscape. After 15 minutes, Lucifer could no longer sense his presence anymore. He was worried that Satan might have detected him and would return soon, but this was worth the risk. Lucifer had always been one to ask questions, and his biggest question was always unanswered. *How did Lord Satan discover the secret of forced evolution, and why is he so much faster than all the other demons?*

Lucifer darted down, skipping nimbly over anything that might make even the slightest sound. Arriving at the rubble, he quickly shoved it aside, climbed in, and covered it back up. Before climbing down into the hole, however, he set a motion detector, just in case Satan should happen to return.

And thusly, he set to crawling down a small tunnel towards an unknown destination.

* * *

Lucifer crawled for a while, trying to figure out if he would get stuck, but as he went on, the tunnel widened slightly, and suddenly he was in a massive room, though it was pitch black.

Lucifer stepped into the room, his heart beating rapidly. *Something isn't right about this place? There's something here, and I can't tell what it is. I've never sensed anything like this bef-*

Before he could finish that thought, something in the room *moved* and he froze. Even with his eyes, trained to see in the dark, his entire body trembled as something incredibly huge

seemed to shift in the darkness.

And then *it* spoke, a deep, rumbling voice that seemed to be like quiet thunder in the silence of the cave.

" Hmmm. You are not my minion, Satan. You must be one of those who are digging tirelessly to free me. "

As Lucifer's eyes adjusted to the darkness, he gasped, as the massive black form of a dragon appeared in the darkness. Standing up to its full height, the dragon must have been 200 feet tall. Lucifer was visibly shaking now. Not one to show his emotions, in took all his self control to not scream out in terror.

"W-who are you?"

The dragon's eyes shifted from black to red. **" I see. You are not one of the miners. My name is Leviathan, the greatest King of Darkness this universe has ever known. Tell me your name now, little mouse, or I will devour you. "**

The dragon's voice spoke softly, but with incredible malice. "My name is- it is Lucifer. I am the third lord of the demons, with only Diablo and Satan above my post."

The dragons' glowing red eyes seemed to flare for a moment as he processed this information. **" Hmm. I see. You are one of the highest generals under Satan, yet you know not of my name or that I even existed here. Why are you here, then, if not to free me from this prison? "**

Lucifer looked around. It was a plain old cave. Given the power of this dragon, why did he simply not just dig his way out? How did he get down here? Best not to question it until they were on normal speaking terms. *As if such a thing existed.*

"I followed my general here. I beg your forgiveness, I could tell that he was hiding something from our people, but I knew not what it was. In my search for knowledge, I have done something unforgivable and treasonous." Lucifer bowed quickly, as he awaited the dragon's response.

Leviathan paused for a number of seconds, his eyes probing the demon at his feet. **" You appear to speak truth. However, either Satan is lying to me, or you are. If Satan is not digging me out of this prison, then what is he doing for me? "**

Lucifer lifted himself back up to gaze at the awesome sight of the dragon. "I beg your forgiveness, my lord. Satan has told nobody of your existence... I fear that he must be lying to you, though to what end I know not."

The dragon nodded slowly as he slumped back down to the floor. Lying down flat on his stomach, he brought his head to ground level as he eyeballed the demon in front of him. " **Any minion who lies to me is no minion I can trust. Satan has lost my favor. However, if you promise me that you will dig me out of this prison, then I will grant you the same powers that I granted him.** "

Lucifer's body was shaking. *This is treason, my lord will surely kill me for this. But... if I were as powerful as he was, then I might just be able to put up a fight...*

"Mighty Leviathan, I have only two questions to ask of you. If you would be so generous, might you answer them?"

Leviathan snorted a tiny gout of black flames. " **...Go on.** "

"Who imprisoned you here? And, though this may be disrespectful, I must ask it as well, why can you not dig yourself out of here?"

The dragon snorted again, this time more fiercely, evidently a form of laughing. " **Ahhh, interesting. Satan never once asked me those questions. You are a perceptive one. To your first question, the answer is that I was buried here due to unfortunate circumstances, but also as the result of a mighty titan of old who sealed me here with holy magic. As to why I cannot dig myself out, it is because this room is not only sealed by his magic, but sure to collapse and crush me if I dig incorrectly. Only one who digs from the surface can free me.** "

Lucifer nodded. "Great Leviathan, King of Darkness, I will agree to free you. Unlike the one who pretends to be my master and who borrows your power for his gain, I will free you from this place. Will you be able to aid us in the crushing of the angelic army, along with the gods of old?"

Leviathan sneered as the black flames sprouted from the side of his mouth. " **A simple task. I will agree to your terms, as you have agreed to mine. Treachery or deceit will result in death.** "

Lucifer pounded his hand on his chest. "I am your loyal servant, Great Leviathan. I will do as you command."

Part 156:

Satan grinned as he walked back into the great hall. Heads immediately turned as his intimidating presence was even more powerful than before, with a sinister dark aura radiating out of his entire body.

"Master Satan! Your evilness eclipses all! Nyahaha!" Some imps danced around his feet as he strode forwards. Even the greatest generals at his table were awed by his presence.

Satan sat down at the table slowly and regally, as befitting a King of the demons. "I have gained something incredible, with this newest evolution, as I expected I would."

Diablo leaned in intently. "My lord, you seem to have gained brilliant power, as you always do. What is your evolution as of now?"

"I am now considered a Demon Lord, I have reached the highest pinnacle that a demon can achieve. However, when I go beyond what a demon can reach, I will become what is known as a 'devil'." Satan grinned broadly as this news passed around the room.

* * *

After some time of strategizing and explaining his new powers, Satan had convinced the other generals and lords at the table that the invasion of Mount Sinai, striking at their home base, would be the most effective way to win the war.

"Your power is certainly formidable, but surely Kronos will be a problem to deal with, hmm?" Diablo stared at the mockup of the battle plans. "He is the strongest titan among the gods, and even then, he would appear to be eclipsed by Gabriel. Will you be able to fight them, two on one?"

Satan grimaced. "It is not ideal, but to be honest, I do not plan to win. I plan to stall while the main forces slay as many angels as possible. Remember, we can simply breed more demons if we need to. Humans can as well. Angels appear to lack that ability, or at least they seem to do it very slowly. If we cut their numbers down, we will win the long war."

Diablo grumbled his approval. "Yes, that makes sense. I don't like the idea of not going in to win decisively, but this works for a long term solution."

As they were speaking, a new voice rang out in the corridors. "Lord Satan! I have returned! And I have learned of your deception."

Satan looked up from the table. *Hmm? Who is that?*

At the end of the hallway, there stood a mighty demon, one with incredible power, in a similar vein as Satan himself. Satan narrowed his eyes. The demon looked familiar, but he couldn't be sure... no... no, this had to be...

"Lucifer? Is that you?" Bael spoke up. "By the great demons! You have gained unbelievable power! You hardly look like the same monster I remember!"

Lucifer nodded grimly as he strode up to the table. "Thank you, Lord Bael, however this is not the time for *pleasantries*." Lucifer glared at Satan. "How long were you planning to deceive our people?"

Satan glared at him. *This whelp. He must have followed me. DAMN! I should have known a darkwalker would be the one to betray me.*

"A deception, you say? Everything I do, I do for the good of our kind. However, you and I should have a talk before you say something you'll regret." Satan decided that he should try and muffle this before the idiot flapped his lips too loosely.

Lucifer stared down at the highest ranking demon, the one declared leader of his people. *He may be a fraud when it comes to the source of his power, but it does stand to reason that he has led us to many great victories and power for our people. I should hear him out first.*

"You speak truth. I will hear what you have to say, and we will decide together what must be done."

Satan's grimace slowly disappeared. *Good, maybe I can get this idiot to shut his trap, before he gets us all killed.*

Part 157:

"You've got some explaining to do."

Lucifer started off the conversation on a sour note, but it couldn't be helped. They were outside now, in a secret, quiet area, where they could speak privately.

Satan nodded sagely as he stared at his third in command. *This one is dangerous, I can't shut him up the quick way, and even if I could, it would create too many questions. I'll just have to outwit him.* Satan quietly mused to himself on how best to rectify the situation.

"You want some explanations, hm? What would you have me explain?"

Lucifer stifled the urge to roll his eyes. *Great, he's going to try and pretend he has no idea what I'm talking about.* "The dark dragon, Leviathan. Why have you hid his existence from us? Why have you not fulfilled his wish and dug him out? Surely he would be a mighty ally on the battlefield."

Satan grimaced in a quiet inner part of his boiling inferno of a soul. *This idiot, he doesn't understand anything. I'll have to teach him.*

"Lucifer, I want to play a small mental exercise game with you. Let's say that instead of hiding knowledge of the dark dragon, I came and told everyone how I truly learned to evolve. What do you suppose would have happened?"

Lucifer paused as he played the situation in his head. "I suppose we would have gotten to work digging him out. It only makes sense."

Satan visibly rolled his eyes. "All right, that's part *one*, what comes afterwards?"

Lucifer paused. "He, ah- the Great Dragon, I mean, would rule over us?"

Satan rubbed his forehead. "You can't be serious. Are you that naive? You think the mighty dark dragon, the most fearsome monster on the side of darkness, would be some benevolent ruler?"

Lucifer, not one to be shaken easily, turned his head away awkwardly. "W-well, when you put it like that..."

"Yes, exactly. That dragon would likely either completely ignore us, or maybe, much more likely, devour or kill us all. That dragon is the most fearsome kind of monster." Satan gesticulated as he explained, and Lucifer nodded slowly, finally getting the bigger picture.

"But still, aren't you playing with fire? You're going to get burned. That dragon would have soon realized nobody was digging down to free him."

Satan sighed heavily, as he sat on a nearby rock. "Lucifer... I have led our people for almost a century now. A hundred years. Leviathan is a cunning and insightful monster. He knows nobody is coming to dig him out. And since that is the case, since it could not possibly take a hundred years to free him, why do you suppose he has not killed me?"

Lucifer also sat down, his face a mix of confusion and doubt. "Because he feels... lonely?"

Satan waved his hands up in the air. "Not the *exact* word I was thinking of, but close enough. That dragon told me he had been trapped there, all alone for generations. He's not exactly lonely, but he most certainly enjoys speaking to someone. If he were to eat me, or kill me, he would have essentially no chance of ever escaping."

Lucifer nodded. "I... see. My lord... I have misjudged you. I thought you did this all for your own gain but... clearly you are wiser than I."

Satan carefully hid a smile behind his hands as he leaned the front of his face in his hands, which rested on his knees. *This youngling is more of a fool than I expected. The story was certainly convincing, but to believe it so readily... he would be a detriment to have as my third or even second in command.*

"Indeed, young one. Never forget, by keeping that dragon enslaved to me, I was able to keep stealing his power to benefit our people. And while you did betray a sacred trust among our people, I am willing to forgive you, under one condition."

Lucifer stopped staring vacantly at the ground and glanced back up to his beloved leader, admiration once again in his eyes. "Of course! It is only just that I should redeem myself!"

Satan felt a cackle rumble up inside him, which he again stifled. *To be young is to be foolish, as they say.* "I have a mission I need completed. To be honest, now that you are a mighty darkwalker who is invisible in the shadows, yet powerful enough to fight even a high ranked god, you are the only one who could ever complete this mission."

Lucifer nodded eagerly. "Of course! Anything! Please tell me!"

Satan stared away, putting a mock expression of sadness on his face. "Well, truth be told, you are too valuable to our people now. I fear even you could not complete this mission without a horrible tragedy overcoming you. In fact, never mind. Yes, this is too dangerous. I'd rather lose one of the lower ranked dark-walkers than lose you."

Lucifer was practically on the edge of his seat at this point. "No, please, my lord! I beg of you! I must redeem myself for my treachery!"

Satan sighed deeply. "Well... it can't be helped then. There is an item of particular value that I need stolen. I have heard of it by means of whispers and muttering. To be honest, I know not if

it truly even exists."

Lucifer nodded again, his eagerness almost overwhelming compared to the calm demeanor of his senior. "Yes! Go on!"

"There exists a twin set of stones, held by the highest of the archangels. A light one, and a dark one. I care not for the light one, but if you should manage to steal the dark one, I would be willing to give you a large portion of its energy, and a full pardon of your treason. However, the mission has a high chance of resulting in your death. I advise against it, for your own safety."

Lucifer leaped to his feet, eagerly bobbing his head. "It will be a trifle! With my new powers, it will be like taking a human baby from an imp!"

Satan nodded, as a sinister smile sprouted in his heart. "I see. I must trust in your abilities then. Should you succeed, you will surely get the reward you deserve."

Lucifer almost leaped for joy. "My lord! Your kindness and generosity knows no bounds! I will forever honor you as the patriarch of our people!"

Lucifer left excitedly, leaving Satan to his thoughts.

Truly, no matter how powerful a pawn becomes, that level of idiocy is inexcusable. If he doesn't die by the hand of the angels, I'll have to do the deed myself.

Part 158: Forbidden

Lucifer stared at the doorway that led into Mount Sinai. As best as he knew, no demon had ever entered this place. Not because it was necessarily not desired, but because to do so would be to wish death upon themselves.

Demons were inherently weaker than angels. Even moreso, when compared with 'gods'. Demons, even when evolving, only tended to gain a small amount of power. Some, however, might gain new abilities, and seldomly, they would gain unique abilities.

Luckily, Lucifer had gained a few of these unique abilities, and now he would be putting them to the test.

Shadowstep.

With a mental command, Lucifer willed himself to instantly transfer from one shadow to another, staying invisible, and not appearing to move at all in the process. An incredible skill meant for the highest of assassins, the benefits of it had many applications, not least of which was extremely fast travel. By using this method of movement, he had easily caught up to his King's early departure by racing after him, traveling from shadow to shadow. That it was nighttime when he left the exit of Leviathan's abode was a lucky coincidence. It allowed him to travel at unbelievable speeds.

In the darkness, none were Lucifer's equal.

However, there was a problem, once he got inside the actual cave, that darkness became very sparing. He was lucky that he could shadowstep anywhere that he had a direct line of sight to a shadow, but when it was so bright that no shadows existed, what then?

Well, he would have to quickly move through the light, hoping that no angels spotted him.

Lucifer was a lucky demon, however. Angels occasionally passed through the halls, but having not seen a demon inside their sanctuary since the dawn of time, they had grown complacent. Even in groups of two or three, they merely chatted with one another, oblivious to their surroundings. The individuals were the most alert ones, but even they seemed to be lost in whatever thoughts angels that had lived for an eternity might have.

And thusly, Lucifer made his way deep inside the mountain.

As he went deeper and deeper, he saw more and more fantastical sights. A beautiful garden, filled with flowing water, green grass and flowers, and fantastical architecture crafted by the finest artisans among the angels. Rocks etched with precise linework, depicting ancient battle

the angels had fought to preserve their way of life. At one point, he could have sworn he even spotted a single ray of sunlight, somehow coming through a hole from the top of the mountain, that landed on a sword stuck fast in a rock. However, as he was in a rush, he mostly ignored it.

Finally he arrived at the place no demon before him had ever seen or could have ever seen without his particular set of skills: The Gateway to Heaven. A portal created by magic of the old ages, which led to an entirely new dimension, one constructed by and for divine beings. One that transcended the known laws of physics, as humans later would come to call them.

Lucifer, hiding in the pale shadow of a giant underground oak tree, pondered his next move. He could see inside the portal, it was like looking through an open doorway. The portal led to some entirely pure white room, the composition of which he could not tell. While he could not get a good look, he knew one thing for sure. *I would be lucky if there were even a single shadow to hide in, so omnipresent is the light in that room.*

Lucifer steeled himself as he watched and waited. For hours, and hours, he sat patiently. He watched as the two cherubs that stood inside the portal, guarding the exit and entrance, stood watch, their arms crossed as they stared directly ahead. In that white room, there would be no way to hide from their gaze.

He considered his options carefully. *In order to enter, perhaps I should kill those two, when no others are around. However, once the bodies are found, or their missing presences are noted, all of the gods and angels will go on a furious hunt to find me. I only have three unique abilities to use, and I should prefer not to show them unless absolutely necessary. There must be a way in.*

As Lucifer pondered his next course of action, something miraculous happened; the cherubs changed guard duty with another being. A weak old-looking man swapped with them, and the two cherubim warriors walked away.

Interestingly, the old man instead stood on this side of the portal, not the inside of that white room.

If I could just create a distraction to make him avert his eyes for but a second, I could slip past into the holy room beyond that gate. Then I will be well on my way to completing the mission.

Lucifer glanced around, moving only his eyes. He spotted a small tree root at his feet, loosened, easy to toss and make a small noise. *Perfect.*

Just as he was about to reach down and grab it, when the corridor was empty, a voice spoke and made him nearly jump out of his skin.

"I suppose you've come to say hello, then."

Part 159:

As Lucifer pondered who that old man could be, one who appeared defenseless, leaning on an old gnarled cane with a long white beard, dressed in a grey bedraggled robe, a voice spoke out.

"I suppose you've come to say hello, then."

Lucifer's blood froze, as he heard the voice speak. *That voice... it sounded like it came from the old man. W-was he speaking to another angel in the room? Aren't he and I the only two here?*

Lucifer carefully and silently leaned the corner of his eye around the tree. Even someone with perfect eyesight would be hard pressed to see him.

The old man was gone. He no longer stood by the door.

As Lucifer's pounding heart slammed in his chest, the voice spoke again, this time from right next to him. "It is impolite to ignore your elders, young demon."

Lucifer yelped in fright as he whipped his head around and saw the old man standing mere feet away, his eyes closed in thought yet appearing to see right through him. He still leaned on his mangled looking old cane, a walking stick that appeared to have simply been pulled from a tree and neither shaped nor cut, yet was still essential for his movement.

"H-h-how d-did you see me?!" His nerves shot, Lucifer tripped on a tree root and stumbled to the ground. He quickly regained his footing and took a fighting stance.

"Are you a fool? I am the wisest of the angels, known as one of the three top archangels. I knew you were here from the moment you entered this sacred ground." The old man smiled, but it was not a smile laced with venom or hatred. It was a pure smile, showing love and sovereignty and possessing a simple, elegant purity.

As Lucifer stood there, his right fist clutching one of his knives at the ready, yet his whole body still shaking from nerves, his heart screamed at him *if I fight this old man, I will not be the victor.*

"Who are you?" Lucifer decided to try the direct approach.

"My name is not important. What is more important is the other question you should be asking. *Why have I been quietly giving you openings and chances to arrive here at this gate by breaking up the appearances of angels as you traveled along?*" The old man, his eyes still closed and a smile still on his face, waved a single finger in the air chidingly.

Lucifer paused. "You... allowed me to come here? To... what end?"

"It's simple. I wished to speak to you. You are either a bold fool, or a courageous idiot, to walk straight into the entrance of the enemy's lair, all by yourself, without so much as checking for traps. Did you really think it was so easy?"

Lucifer grimaced. *He's mocking me. Those are the same things...* "I'm here on a mission, and I will do anything to complete it."

The old man sighed as he pulled himself down to a sitting position, placing his behind on a slightly elevated tree root. *He is sitting down? Is he deliberately giving me an easy opening to attack?*

"A mission, hm? I suppose it could be anything, really. Perhaps you were sent to kill a top leader of ours. Maybe sent to conduct espionage or to destroy something important. Or... perhaps to even... *steal something...* "

The old man's eyes and face, still frozen in that same position as before, betrayed no emotion, but his voice did. *He knows why I'm here.* Lucifer thought to himself.

"How did you find out my mission? Who are you?" Lucifer took a step back as thoughts raced through his mind.

The old man shrugged slightly. "I hear words from these people and those, small tales pass my way, and rumors escape my lips. Naturally, when I 'accidentally' let loose one particular nugget, I realized this could unfortunately draw in some foolhardy youth, seeking respect from his elders. It would appear that I was *correct* in that assumption."

Lucifer could almost feel his lips snarling. *This... was a deliberate trap? Set by this old man? Wait, perhaps he was working with Satan to eliminate me? No, that makes no sense, perhaps he let rumors of the dark orb slip so that Satan would send one such as me. Perhaps-*

The old man chuckled softly. "You seem so quiet. You must have so many thoughts rolling around in that small, easily confused pea pod that you amusingly call a 'brain'. It must be difficult for you, to think harder than you've ever thought before in your life, and still have no idea what reality is."

Lucifer's tiny snarl became a large, nasty, visible one. "Stop playing word games! Why are you here? Why are you speaking to a demon casually? Why is an old man dressed in rags while living among angels and gods?!"

The old man chuckled again. "Ahhhh ha ha! There it is, the questions! I was waiting for those! Does it bother you, that I know more about this situation than you do? Does it bother you, that right now you are helplessly dancing in the palm of my hand?"

Lucifer glared at the old man as rage started to form in his eyes. "You little... mocking me, making fun of me... answer my questions, or I'll cut you down right where you stand!"

The old man's smile suddenly vanished and his eyes shot open as a dark aura suddenly sprouted out of his body. His voice was filled with venom and fire and brimstone. "**You dare threaten me? One who has lived for ten eternities? One who has the power to foretell destiny itself? Even if I lacked the power to crush you myself, *which I do not*, I could summon an army of gods and angels in an instant with a single word. Know your place, you vile *worm*.**"

Lucifer's body involuntarily jerked back at the old man's sudden drastic shift in tone as he stumbled back and tripped on his own feet, stumbling out of the darkness and into the light. There were no angels around, and in fact no other life aside from himself and the old man, but out in the light he felt naked and exposed. "N-no offense meant! It was- it was a jest! Said in haste! H-haha...!"

The old man's eyes instantly normalized as did his expression. The familiar smile returned as did his playful tone of voice. "Splendid! I was worried for a second there that you were going to do something *especially stupid*! But it seems my fears were of no concern, you are brighter than most I have encountered!"

Lucifer climbed back up to his feet, his entire body shaking as he stood out in the open. *I'm going to die here, and I never got close to finding that damned orb. I have failed everyone.*

The old man sat and stared silently for a few seconds before finally getting up and walking past Lucifer towards the Gate to Heaven. "Stay here, boy. I will be right back. You may try and flee if you wish, but such an insult towards my generosity will only bring you a swift death."

As the old man left, Lucifer quickly darted back to the darkness behind the tree, where he felt safer. *What the devil are these games this grandfather is playing with me? Why is he not killing me, if he is an angel or a god? And if he is neither of those, why is he living among them as an equal? Do angels and gods have their own forms of monsters, as demons do, that are neither angel nor god, but live among them as brothers?*

* * *

After a while, nearly an hour, Lucifer was beginning to feel very nervous. The entire way to the Gate to Heaven had been filled with angels moving back and forth, yet for an entire hour, he had not seen even a single one moving around since after that old man's arrival. *Something isn't right.*

Just as he was starting to get itchy enough to consider fleeing for his life back home from whence he came, the old man arrived, walking out of the portal and towards Lucifer. In his

hand, he clenched a small, pure black orb, that seemed to draw in the light around it, converting it into terrible and terrifying amounts of dark energy.

"Here boy, take this trifle, and begone. This dark object has disturbed the sanctity of Heaven for long enough. But be warned, if you take this orb, only madness and a dark future will await you. Nobody who accepts its power ever has a long life. Only darkness, misery, and death await them."

Lucifer stared at the orb, his mouth gaping as he looked at it. *This old man had the orb the entire time? Who the devil IS he? And more importantly, why would he give it to me so easily?!*

He quickly, but respectfully reached over and took the orb from the old man's hand. *Best to not look a gift horse in the mouth, hehehe.* "I thank you for your generosity, ancient one. Will you not tell me your name?"

The old man smiled and bowed politely. "No, *Lucifer*, that will not be necessary. Take the orb and begone. And... do not thank me. Possessing that cursed object is hardly worth thanking me for. Rather, you should curse me forever for heaping such a lamentable fate upon you."

Without waiting for a reply, the old man turned and walked back towards the gate, giving a flippant wave as he turned again and stood at the door once more.

Lucifer, not understanding why any of the events that just transpired even happened, waved back at the old man as he took his leave.

* * *

Raphael watched as the imbecilic young demon left, heading back up the way he had come from. *The young never think before they act. This is why the demons will never pose a real threat to the angels... they are young and stupid, compared to our age and wisdom.*

As the young demon disappeared from his sensory range, he sighed, leaning again upon his staff and hobbling back inside the gate. *I think I'm going to go relax for a while. I've earned it with this.*

Part 160:

Lucifer raced down the halls, running as fast as he could, the pitch black orb of darkness in his hand. While running, he realized that there was still not a *single* angel anywhere to be seen.

It's so strange, why have they all vanished? Did that geezer order them out of the halls? Perhaps there's something happening that requires their attention? Thoughts raced inside his head as he charged down the halls.

As he ran, a strange thing happened. He started hearing things, like a voice inside his head. The voice was strange, however. It took the form of male, then female, sometimes a child, sometimes an old person, it changed tempo and volume, pitch and speed, the voice was like a cacophony of people vying to be heard.

Finally, Lucifer erupted out of the cave, dashing down the hill as he shadowstepped into a nearby shadow, rushing through other shadows until he was a good distance away, before finally halting to catch his breath. His head pounded from the mental noise, as he placed the orb on the ground in front of him and he slumped down, crossing his legs in a meditative position as he paused to catch his breath.

A few minutes passed, as his breathing slowed, but something else was... *off*. He couldn't clear his mind. The orb was no longer in contact with his body, but still the voices remained. As he sat, they started becoming more clear and precise, until a female voice materialized in his mind.

"Who... are you?" The voice sounded young, like the voice of a teenage girl, but with a hint of a demonic edge to it. It had a sort of hissing sound, like she was sharply exhaling as she spoke, reminiscent of someone trying to speak after being stabbed.

Lucifer stared at the orb in front of him. *Should I answer? Why not?* "My name is Lucifer. And yours?"

"My name? It's... Sapphire. Just call me Sapphire." She sounded nice enough, which Lucifer found strange, given that she was a voice inside an incredibly evil looking orb.

"Alright, Sapphire. So... what now? I picked you up from an old man who claimed he was an archangel, but I know nothing about you. Is there anything I need to know?"

The girl seemed to mull his words over. "An old man? I don't know of who you speak. I don't even know where I am."

Lucifer found himself staring quizzically at the orb. *She doesn't know? What the devil kind of strange joke is this?* "Alright, so let's cut to the chase. I want to know how to use your power. Surely, as an orb of darkness, you can make me stronger somehow?"

"Huh? An orb of darkness? What are you talking about?" The girl sounded genuinely confused. "I'm just a normal girl. I was raised in a small village, I live now with my three brothers, though there have been a strange number of monster attacks in the area. Rumors say that there's a vampire on the loose, but my brothers have the divine protection of the gods, so they will protect me if that monster attacks."

Lucifer's jaw hung open as he listened. *What?! What is this stupid girl going on about?? She's supposed to be inside this insanely powerful orb of darkness, how can she possibly think she's still alive?!*

Lucifer took a deep breath and calmed his thoughts, as he responded to the voice that was speaking to him telepathically. "Okay, let us try again. You are a strange orb of absolute darkness that sucks in all light around it. You are clearly not some normal girl, despite whatever you might think you are. Do you remember anything that happened to you recently?"

The girl didn't reply for a half a minute or so, before hesitantly asking a question. "I'm... not alive anymore? I'm... dead?"

Lucifer frowned. "Dead? I don't... think so... you are speaking right now. I mean, maybe you're dead, I have no clue. You tell me!"

The girl seemed to be holding back tears as she spoke. "I... I can't be dead! My brothers, they would protect me! They always protected me..."

Lucifer frowned. "You are a disembodied voice speaking from inside a pitch black orb. I have no goddamn idea *what* you are. Stop playing games with me!"

"No! NO! I CAN'T BE DEAD! WHO KILLED ME?! WHY?! WHY DIDN'T SAM AND RANDOLF PROTECT ME?! THEY FAILED ME! NO!!!"

As the distraught girl screamed, a massive pounding smashed around inside Lucifer's head, as he reeled in pain. The orb grew darker and darker as she screamed, until a few seconds later, her voice was cut off. She vanished.

A new voice appeared in Lucifer's mind, as the pounding stopped. This one was a male voice, definitively demonic. "Ahh, what happened? Where am I?"

Lucifer reeled back in horror. He recognized that voice. "President Valac?! One of the 14 generals under Satan?! You... you DIED! 5 years ago!"

Valac quieted down. "Ah. So that's how it is."

Part 161: Valac

As Lucifer spoke with Valac, a mental image of his old friend's face began to form. He could at first see only a vague outline, but as the minutes crawled by and Valac's mind seemed to gain understanding of his current situation, he became less fuzzy and more pronounced. Soon, the face that spoke in Lucifer's mind was identical to the demon who had lost his life in the Great War some years earlier.

"I see. So we're losing this war now?" Valac lowered his gaze, seeming to look at the ground. "I had thought that eventually, Lord Satan would begin to prevail against the weak and simple-minded humans. I feel shame, knowing that I died during such an easy time compared to what you face now."

Lucifer nodded grimly. "Times are desperate. But... there is more. I found the secret to Satan's power, and because of what I discovered, in order to atone for my sins, Satan sent me to Mount Sinai, the location of the angels' home base, in order to retrieve this black orb."

Valac stared ahead blankly. His youthful expression belied his battle-scarred young body and all the years he had fought, not just as a demon who had evolved, but his fighting for survival as an imp. His special ability had been one that allowed him to find special treasure, the kind of ability that would normally lead someone to finding a rare artifact, such as the black orb he now resided in. *It is a cruel irony that he is now sealed inside an orb that he might have been able to find with his powers before he died.* Lucifer shook his head as he waved away the thought.

Lucifer hastily explained to Valac about Leviathan, how Satan had spared him, and his mission to find the black orb. Valac chuckled. "Hehehe... for a demon, you are remarkably pure hearted... and naive. You believe Satan did this for you to redeem yourself? He expected you to die, to be killed by the angels when you invaded their sacred grounds. This was anything but a chance for redemption, unless he expected you to redeem yourself by *dying*."

Lucifer stared at the orb and the face in his mind grimly, as thoughts swirled inside his head. "So... Satan wanted me to die? Then... I will likely never be trusted, ever again... even if I should return."

Valac grimaced for a second. *Sheesh, this guy is way too nice to be a demon. I should let him off easy.* "Look, kid, let me be frank. I don't know what my abilities are as an orb, and I can't predict the future, but anyone with half a brain knows that you will be betrayed by Satan at

some point if you return. You simply *know too much*. If you go back there, you might as well sign your name in blood on a suicide contract, you get me?"

Lucifer nodded. "Then... if I cannot return, what can I do?"

Valac pondered it for a moment. "I'm not sure, but the first thing that springs to mind should be simple. Don't! Don't go back. Instead, strike out on your own. Together, you and I can gain our own power. We can help our people in the shadows, where we belong. Satan probably thinks you're dead anyway, so he'll do some sappy sad ceremony, yadda yadda, and then replace you. But you'll go on living your own life. Given time, anything could happen. What if Satan dies? Maybe you could even replace him as leader!"

Lucifer jerked his head up in alarm. "R-replace Satan?! No... no! I couldn't do that! Diablo would crush me easily!"

Valac mentally smacked himself in the face. "Boy, you're a real dim one, ain't ya? Look, you said yourself that Leviathan boosted your evolutionary abilities all the way to Satan's level right? That makes you practically *equal* with him! And Satan is WAY above all the other demons, so that means *you are too*! Who better to lead the demons if Satan passes, than one who is his equal, who is a literal agent of the darkness, and who possesses some fancy dark orb?"

Lucifer turned from the orb and stared ahead blankly at a tree. "Your words... they have truth to them. Now that you mention it... perhaps Satan sent me away to get killed because he feared my power... if I'm as strong as you say, then it could result in a humiliating defeat for him."

Valac nodded. "Yes, now you get the point. So you would be perfect to take over for him if he dies!"

Lucifer grinned. "No... no... don't you see? I was his equal before I left. But now, I have *you*, and if I can just learn to harness your energy, I can easily crush Satan and take over as the Demon King. Then we will move on to other things, like erasing the angels and the gods from existence!"

Valac's face turned deathly white. "Uh, no, that's a bad idea. *Very bad*. I like you, okay? But I still respect Satan. He may have gotten his power through illicit means and he may have lied to our people, but I understand why he did it. Satan is a brilliant leader, and we need him to lead us through this war, until we have crushed the angels, and beyond."

Valac paused, as a sneer appeared on his face. "Besides, no offense, but as strong as you are, even if you used my power, I don't think you *can* beat Satan. I fought him in a mock battle once. He didn't even use brute force, he outwitted me a hundred times over, it was a crippling

embarrassment. You may be a red-skinned demon, but you're too *green*, kid. You'd never beat him as you are now."

Lucifer stared back at the face in his mind. "You think so, hm? I think... you are wrong. I can beat him. I can defeat him."

Valac grimaced. "Cheh! Fine, go ahead and try. But don't ask me for help. I won't give you any. I refuse to give treasonous aid to one who would harm my king."

Lucifer ground his teeth together. "I... don't think you understand the *position* you're in. I'm not *asking* you to help me. I'm going to *take* your power, whether you want to give it to me or not. I am the master, and you are my servant."

Valac stared up numbly at Lucifer, as his eyes filled with greed. He bit his lip as he looked away. "...Yes. I thought so. You're not half the demon Satan is. Do what you must then, I wash my hands of it."

Lucifer quickly clamped both hands on the orb. "Shut up! **Give!** "

He concentrated intensely, as he felt dark power flowing from the orb into his hands and through those, into his body. He quietly started laughing, and the volume increased as more and more power flowed into his body.

" Yes! With this power, I will RULE over the demons! Ahhh hahahaha!!! "

* * *

Raphael stood inside Heaven's domain, sipping a strange brothy mixture, staring into a pure white orb of incredible brilliance, as a spectacle unfolded in front of him. The young demon who had so casually taken the Orb of Death was now transformed into a greedy power-hungry monster.

"As I expected." He muttered to himself. "The young are always foolish."

Part 162:

Lucifer leaped through the shadows, as the sun beamed down overhead. It was late day now, and he was quickly drawing near to the 'fortress of evil', as it had been nicknamed by its residents. Not exactly a brilliant name, but if it works, it works!

As the fortress was buried in the side of a mountain, in a vein similar to the angels' and gods' mountain entrance, it was a particularly well fortified and guarded place. A siege would take forever to complete, and for some reason, their location either had not been discovered, or the angels and humans were simply too fearful to attack.

Lucifer shadow-walked the last bit of distance towards the gate, and appeared directly in the middle of the doorway, his appearances causing one drowsy guard to scream in terror and fall to the ground. "Ah! Y-your nastiness, Great Lucifer! I beg forgiveness!"

Lucifer nodded down at the tiny imp. *If I were leader, he would not get his rations for the day.* "Get back to your post, and stop slacking or an evolution will be hard for you to find."

The imp nodded quickly. "Y-yes, your evilness! I-I will return to my duties at once!"

Good. Lucifer thought to himself. *They are scared of my power, as they should be. I am truly mighty now, thanks to the power of this orb.*

Lucifer glanced down at the orb. Valac's presence in his mind had gone completely silent since he took the powers of the orb earlier. He couldn't tell if Valac was still in there, or if he was simply giving Lucifer the silent treatment. *It is of no consequence. Once I best Satan in battle, he will have to acknowledge my power.*

* * *

Satan kicked his feet up at the table, as one of the female demons cooed in his ear. He turned to her and leaned in for a kiss, but was swiftly rejected. "Ah, Belial. Your beauty increases with every evolution. I am truly impressed by how much more attractive you appear every time I see you."

Belial, one of his uniquely evolved minions, smiled at him and giggled. "Oh, Satan, you're always such a charmer! But you'll have to work a little harder than that to get a taste of what *I've* got to offer!"

Satan licked his lips as he eyed her figure up and down. Before he could respond, however, the door to his private dining hall was wrenched open as someone on the other side kicked it open with a single smooth motion.

Satan glared in the direction of the door. "Who goes there? Why have you disturbed me?"

To his surprise, it was Lucifer that entered the room. *Hmm? It seems the whelp didn't have the guts to enter the mountain after all, what a sh- WHAT?!* He spotted the black orb in Lucifer's hand in the blink of an eye. *How did that little shit get hold of it so quickly?! How did he get hold of it at **all**?!*

Lucifer grinned at the expression on Satan's face. "Hello, *Lord* Satan. So nice of you to recognize me." He sarcastically emphasized the word *lord*, as if to mock Satan and pretend he was unworthy of the title. On top of that, implying Satan was of such a lowly station was a grave insult.

Satan's look of surprise quickly vanished as he quickly stood up from his seat. "You... I see you brought back the orb. Truly, I am glad for your return. With these, we can put the matter beh-"

Lucifer quickly interrupted him. "You tried to *trick* me, didn't you? I was able to slay fifteen angels, and I even had a titanic clash with an archangel, all to receive this orb. It boosted my powers by a magnitude of three! You are below me now!"

Satan kept his expression even. *He fought with an archangel and lived to tell the tale? He might be lying, but then, I cannot be sure. And if he has the orb, he is surely going to be a tough opponent. Best to take this one slowly.*

"Calm down, Lucifer. You seem to be angry about something. Why not have a seat? We can sit down and discuss this like mature demons." He beckoned at a chair next to Lucifer. Without even looking at it, Lucifer whipped out his hand and smashed the Demonstone chair into a thousand pieces.

It would take an incredible amount of force to destroy Demonstone like that. This youth is no joke. Satan kept his eyes level and did not even so much as glance at the shattered chair remnants. The other demon generals in the room quietly sipped their drinks, and Belial casually played with her hair, as she feigned boredom.

"I won't let you talk down to me. Not anymore, betrayer. You lie and cheat to boost yourself up, but no more! I challenge you to an Agni Kai! We will duel each other to the death, and the winner claims the throne of Demon King!"

Satan grimaced. *He's... still a fool. He showed such promise in the beginning with his espionage and secrecy, but in the end...*

Satan lowered his head. "I accept your challenge, Lucifer. But know this, I did not get to where I am simply due to raw power. The position of Demon King was won through hard work

and sacrifice. There are days when it is a true burden. I believe that if you were to become the Demon King, our race would surely go extinct in a matter of months. With that being said, I will not allow you to destroy our people with your youth and inexperience. I will not lose, that is the one thing you can be sure of."

Lucifer grinned evilly as he licked his lips. *I've already won. I've already won. I've already won.* Three words kept replaying in his head, as he glanced over at the form of Belial. *Soon, she and many others will be mine. They have wasted themselves on a limp-wristed fool like Satan. His conquests in the bedroom are nonexistent, just as his life will soon be. I've already won.*

Satan waved his hand at the youth. "Tomorrow, at the break of dawn, we will fight. Now get out, I'm still the Demon King, and you are no longer the third highest, by my decree. Take your filth out of the caves, you will sleep in the cold tonight."

Lucifer paused for a split second, then grinned. "Weakening your opponent by making him stay outside for the night, heh. Very clever of you to use tricks as you always do."

Satan grimaced. "If sleeping outside for a single night would weaken you, I can already tell you will be no challenge at all."

Lucifer's grin faded, and he turned and walked out the door, slamming it behind himself.

Belial turned over to look at Satan. "Well, *I* thought it was amusing, at least."

Part 163: Honor

Lucifer and Satan faced each other. They were standing out in a meadow some distance from the Fortress of Evil, as millions of imps, scythers, and other such demons watched from the nearby hills, from hastily made platforms, from the air (A few could fly, but only the highly evolved ones) and other such places.

Whooping and cheering could be heard. To Lucifer's dismay, most of the demons were cheering for Satan, not for himself. *Oh well, if they underestimate me, it will only make my powers that much more spectacular. Even Satan has no idea of what I am capable of.*

Satan eyed the youth warily. *Yes, he has become mighty, but I still have the upper hand in intelligence, and my newest special ability will likely give me the upper hand. I must win, at all costs.*

Lucifer pointed at Satan with his pinky, a sign of great disrespect. "Today, you will die, and I will rule our people! I am more fit than you to lead!"

Satan scoffed. "You may have the power, but you lack the discipline to lead tens of millions of demons."

"Hah! DISCIPLINE?! More than 60 million demons have died in the last few months under your leadership! They are dying by the droves thanks to your weakness and inability to crush Hercules!" As Lucifer spoke, a tiny portion of the crowd started murmuring to themselves.

Satan glanced around. *I need to start the battle and end him quickly. It is fortunate that he has not yet spoken about Leviathan, though he may be planning to kill me and take Leviathan's powers for himself, along with that orb.*

"All right whelp, you've had your fun, now let's see if you are any better with your fists than you are with your weapons."

Lucifer's grin expanded mightily. "Oh, *you will see*, great leader. You will see."

* * *

The battle took off with a start. Lucifer, instead of charging head on, quickly punched the ground repeatedly, causing minor tremors in the ground, and causing it to split and heave all over the battlefield as irregularities appeared. More importantly, many spots of ground shot up, creating *shadows* where they blocked the sunlight.

Cheh. Smart move, and here I thought a sprawling meadow might give me an advantage. Maybe he's not as stupid as I thought. Satan watched warily as small shadows appeared here

and there. Shadows didn't have to be big for Lucifer to transfer himself, they only needed to be *dark*.

In a flash, Lucifer disappeared and reappeared behind Satan, silently leaping forwards with his knife and stabbing at Satan's back. However, Lucifer was only fast when he transferred from shadow to shadow, which happened instantly. Out in the open, he moved at only an above-average speed.

Satan was fast *all* the time.

In the time it took for Lucifer to jump from his hiding spot, Satan had already spotted him and formed a plan. As the young one leaped towards him, Satan squatted down in a flash, scooped up some dirt, and whipped around, heaving it into Lucifer's eyes.

"Gragh!" Lucifer yelled in surprise as his vision blurred. Swiping wildly at the air, he scored no hits on his predecessor. But Satan did. Satan quickly reached around and punched Lucifer directly in the face, sending him flying into one of the earthen mounds he had created with his first attack earlier.

Lucifer hissed air angrily, and after a quick blink and rub, his eyes were clear again. "Always with the tricks!" In an instant, he disappeared again.

Satan quickly moved his hands around as he cast a hasty spell. It didn't need to do much, only distract the youth. Superior battle tactics had always been what won Satan his victories, not usually brute force.

Lucifer once again leaped from the shadows behind Satan, as Satan expected. *So predictable.*

Lucifer swiped at Satan's unmoving body again, but yelled in surprise as it vanished from the air. "A mirage?!" He quickly looked around but didn't see Satan as he continued flying through the air, flailing his limbs around.

"Under you." A voice said, as Satan erupted from underground, delivering a mighty blow directly to Lucifer's abdomen. The breath blasted out of his body as he went flying up at a crooked angle, and then smashed into the ground. He panted and wheezed for breath, but out of the corner of his eye, Satan charged at him on the offensive. Satan grabbed one of his feet, and before Lucifer could respond, he was smashed around like a child's toy.

WHAM! WHAM! WHAM! Satan smashed him from the left to the right and back to his left again, as he left a crumpled mess of a demon lying on the ground. "It is over. Surrender now and I will spare your life."

Lucifer coughed weakly as he lay on the ground. "No... y-you will not defeat me and let me live in shame... I won't allow it!" Suddenly, Lucifer, who had been holding the black orb tightly in his off hand the whole time, cupped it with his right hand. " **Power!!** "

Instantly, his wounds healed themselves, and within a couple seconds, he was standing fully upright again.

"All right then, *dear leader*, I've gotten a good grasp on your abilities. Time for me to get serious."

Part 164:

Lucifer grinned wickedly as he stood once again, trembling with power. In the blink of an eye, he raised his hand up, quickly casting a spell, as a strange black fog flooded the lands.

Shadows were everywhere, and the audience was having a tough time seeing what was going on.

Lucifer vanished, then reappeared, then vanished and reappeared, over and over again. He began moving so fast that Satan was having a tough time seeing where he had just appeared. Suddenly, a punch smashed into Satan's chest as Lucifer shadow-stepped while moving, his hand hitting Satan at nearly the speed of sound. The WHUMP was muffled due to Satan's chest strength, but the impact was not. Satan went smashing backwards, tumbling end over end unceremoniously until he came to a stop on his back.

He started to get up, but Lucifer appeared underneath him, using the shadow Satan's body itself cast on the ground. In a flash, he wrapped his strong arms and legs around Satan, and started squeezing hard. Pinning Satan's arms and legs down, he squeezed so hard that in a flash Satan's limbs made horrifying snapping sounds as he screamed in pain.

Belial and the audience watched in horror as Lucifer squeezed Satan tightly enough that his very being seemed to shatter.

And then, something odd happened. Lucifer started to scream instead, as his own bones started to break. He quickly let go and shadow stepped away, falling to the ground. "A-ah... you... bastard! What the devil just happened?!"

Satan, still lying flat on his back in agony, forced a smile. "Hehe, 'pain transfer'. It's not even a high level technique. You made prolonged painful skin contact with me, so I transferred it back to you. Now we're both in bad shape... hehe." Satan coughed and spit some blood out of his mouth.

Lucifer grimaced as he quickly used the orb again, once more healing his body. "What now? You're broken and I am not."

Satan laughed weakly. "Go ahead, try it. I have a surprise in store for you, if you've got the guts to attack a defenseless Devil with broken arms and legs."

Lucifer narrowed his eyes. *A bluff to be sure. He can't even cast spells as he is now.*

He instantly disappeared, reappearing next to Satan's body, as he reared his hand back to smash it into the ground.

Satan's weak and pathetic looking smile disappeared, as a massive one overtook his face. "**Heh heh heh, young fool, you played right into it. Game over.**"

In the blink of an eye, an invisible hand smashed into Lucifer's face, sending him reeling back. Suddenly, more invisible attackers pounded him all over, some from the front, some from the sides, each blow feeling like he was being smashed with iron rods.

In the span of three seconds, his body was pummeled, beaten, and masticated over fifty times. And out of nowhere, the blows stopped, as he reeled back and fell to the ground. Satan rose up, as he appeared to float in the air without actually moving his broken body.

"I never wished for this to happen. You were third under me, a top general. You've led many battles and won through brute force, always killing from the shadows. A top agent, to be sure. But now, look at you. You can't win against me. I possess the ultimate attack, and the ultimate defense. My final trump card."

Lucifer gasped and wheezed as he lay on the ground. He had dropped the orb while being beaten, it lay only a few feet from his hand. But to him, it may as well have been a million leagues away. His arms were twisted in unnatural directions. His legs were snapped in half, his face beaten beyond comprehension. His breath came in ragged gasps.

"H-how? I... had... power... to beat you..." He rasped weakly, as blood trickled from his mouth to the grass his face pressed against.

Satan shrugged. "What good is brawn without brains? What good is all the power in the world, if you lack the wisdom to use it properly? You were destined to lose, no matter what. You were not even close to being a strong opponent. In fact, you were the weakest I have ever faced."

Satan leaned in close to Lucifer, his body still hovering stiffly in the air somehow. "*And make no mistake, you were unworthy of what Leviathan gave you.*"

Satan quickly righted his stiff body upwards. "The battle is over. Farewell, Lucifer."

In a single instant, another invisible blow came from nowhere, the power ten times what the previous ones were. It smashed into Lucifer's head, crushing his skull instantly. His brains exploded and bits and pieces flew all over as the crowd roared with delight.

Lucifer, the third General of the demons, was dead.

Part 165:

Satan floated in the air, as he gazed down at the badly mutilated corpse of his former disciple. *This wasn't just a waste, it was a damned tragedy, losing one with such a hopeful future as him.* Satan scornfully mourned the passing of Lucifer for a few moments, and then he turned around to face the crowd.

"I hope we've all learned what happens when you not only disrespect me, but our entire race of people."

The crowd silently nodded quickly, not wishing to speak.

Satan glanced around. "Belial? Where are you? I need to be healed, since my arms and legs are broken."

Belial cheerfully hopped up towards him. "O~kay! But..." She leaned in close and whispered in his ear. "...I want to know what he knew that made you have to silence him. Deal?"

Satan rolled his eyes. *Women, such troublemakers... but she has much potential, unlike... that corpse over there...*

"Very well. I could just order one of the other healers, but since I like you, why not come to my bedchambers tonight, and I'll tell you all about it?"

Belial sighed. "You men, always only one thing on your minds. But this time, I don't mind! I will consider it a fair trade." She waved her hands around while muttering some unheard words, and Satan felt his body gently mending itself. Unlike the other healers, she was the best. She had full control over her healing ability, and could jam the broken pieces together cruelly, or mend them together sweetly and softly.

Satan sighed with relief as the frankly agonizing pain left him. "Tell you what, Belial. Throw in a backrub, and I'll let you keep that blackened orb over there. My body is very stiff from that fight."

She shrugged. "I don't really want it. It's pretty icky and not that fun looking. BUT, since it's a present from you, Lord Satan, I'll accept~!"

She walked over to it, picking it up daintily as a quick expression of revulsion and disgust washed over her face, then passed as quickly as it had appeared. "S-such a fine gift! I will.... treasure it..." Her voice hinted that she actually thought it was nauseating, but then she never was one to get her hands dirty.

She walked back over and locked her arm around Satan's, giggling as the two of them walked away.

Before they took ten steps, Satan turned his head back around. "Bael. Go clean up that stain on the lawn. It's unsightly."

* * *

"Ooooh, that was pretty good. You must have a lot of experience~!" Belial quickly put her clothes back on and stepped out of bed as she tossed her hair back. "I did my part of the bargain, so it's your turn!"

Satan, lying on his stomach, jerked his thumb at his back. "The backrub, if you please. I'll explain it as we go along."

Belial smiled prettily. "You really *are* a devil." She climbed back on the bed and perched herself on his rear as she started to rub. "So, what was so important to hide that you wouldn't even spare Lucifer? He was your 3rd in command, you know."

Satan groaned heavily as her fingers dug into his thick red skin, softening up his tight muscles. *I can't imagine Heaven being much better than this.* "Well, Lucifer stumbled onto something he shouldn't have. I really wouldn't even be telling you this, but you're not a nitwit like he was, so I know I can trust you."

"Aww, that's so sweet of you! But Diablo is your highest ranked officer below yourself. Can't you even tell him?"

Satan shook his head lightly. "No. I will someday, but for now, the truth needs to be hidden. Telling you this will give you a lot of power, but that is okay."

Belial eyed him curiously as she delicately dug her fingernails into his back. "What makes that okay?"

"It's simple. If I am a king, then I should have a mighty queen by my side! The humans do it, and I should too!"

Belial broke into an explosive laugh. "Hahahaha!! The humans?! They have to mate with each other to have children! Demons come from the underground broodmothers, who spit out imps hour after hour! What good would any bond of matrimony do to you other than split your power?"

Satan hesitated. "Belial... hypothetically... what if I were to be killed by an angel, or a god, or Hercules, as an example? What would happen to the demons if there were no backup?"

Belial stopped her rubbing as she leaned forwards and rested her chin on her arm, lying on his back. "Well, I suppose it wouldn't matter to you, since you would be dead... but it would

leave the demons in disarray, and Diablo would have to step up as King."

Satan sneered. "Exactly! And you and I both know, he is a tough demon, but he is inferior to me in power and intellect. No... I need someone more reliable."

Belial nodded. "All right, I see where you're coming from. So what does any of this have to do with the secret that Lucifer learned of?"

A grin spread across Satan's face. "Belial, it has *everything* to do with it." He carefully got up to a standing position, as she climbed off him. Putting on his royal regalia, he turned to her again. "Come with me, I have something important to show you."

Part 166:

The demons around the table listened quietly as Satan stood over the War Table, explaining the plan to them.

"We're going to take the fight to the angels. As long as Hercules has his human pawns, we stand no chance of defeating him in battle. But, if we can at least destroy the angelic threat, or reduce their fighting strength significantly, we can turn our losses around."

Satan beckoned to his new queen, as Belial stepped forwards. The others at the table had been shocked at first, but now they had accepted that Satan simply had some special ability that granted him immense powers, and somehow he was able to grant those powers to another. Even the accusations of treason by the deceased Lucifer would not deter their loyalty to the king.

Plus, they could barely pull their eyes away from his queen. Belial had grown fantastically more beautiful, and with her recent evolution, she had become even more humanlike and sensual to the eyes. Plump breasts, long flowing blonde hair, and a tall slender body. However, under her facade of beauty, the evolution had also increased her cunning, and her ability to manipulate. She had evolved into a unique race, known as the High Vampire. Unlike lower vampires, she did not require blood for sustenance, though she did gain more power based on how much blood she took in.

Belial smiled, as she leaned over the table, holding the black orb in her hand. A mental image formed in everyone's heads as Valac appeared. Gasps were heard all around as he looked at each one of them.

Bael in particular, was intrigued. "Valac, as I recall, you died more than four years ago, during the Eighteen Day Siege. What black magic is allowing you to appear to us from beyond the grave?"

Valac somehow shrugged in the minds of his listeners. "To be honest, I have no idea! But hey, if I'm dead, at least I can still be alive somehow inside this orb!"

Bael nodded as did the others at the table. Satan spoke next. "Valac has told me some incredible information that Lucifer relayed to him shortly before he challenged me to a duel. After Belial and I went on a little... trip..." Satan glanced over at Belial for a split second and grinned, as she did too, before he flicked his eyes back. "...We found that the orb somehow possessed the soul of our dear comrade, and given that he despised Lucifer's betrayal of our kind, he has graciously told us everything Lucifer told him."

Valac nodded. "Yes. More importantly, it's about the angels. Lucifer, always the liar, claimed he slayed fifteen angels and battled an archangel. That was not only a bald-faced lie, it was a strange one, given that he told me the truth. As I understand it, he was given the orb which I reside in by an... old man. A strange old man who lived among the angels and gods."

Satan sat down in his chair, and beckoned for Belial to sit in the chair next to him, which she did, as she set the orb on the table. "There's more. Lucifer was able to get inside the mountain, and he discovered a magical gate that seemed to lead to an entirely different world. As I long wondered, the angels don't actually live inside the mountain, and neither do the gods. They simply hid the portal to their real base inside Sinai. What this means is that if we invade their base, we can cripple them from within, without allowing Hercules a chance to retaliate with his human armies." Satan almost shook with glee as he explained the plan, but he kept his voice neutral.

One of the younger generals at the table, spoke hesitantly. "My liege, we all know the angels possess fantastic powers. You alone could certainly destroy many angels without our help, but... even the strongest general among us might not be able to fight equally with just one angel, let alone a god. How could we possibly beat them?"

Satan shook his head. "I don't think you understand, young one. We will not win a major victory. We will likewise lose a great many troops, just as the angels will. Millions of our imps and demons will die. *Millions*. Our forces are 35 million strong, only because of a crushing defeat we suffered to Hercules and his army a few days ago. But, we have an advantage the angels and gods do not."

Bael leaned forwards intently. "Oh? Now this sounds interesting. What might that be?"

Belial giggled. "Reproduction!"

The other demons at the table blushed as Bael leaned back. "Oh. That... was not what I had expected."

A grin spread across Satan's face. "Indeed, reproduction. Thanks to a... source... I have learned that angels cannot reproduce. Gods can, especially those born of the titans, but their reproduction is slow. This is the real reason I have deduced that they use humans. Humans are expendable. Angels are finite. They can continue to throw humans at us all they want, but losing just one angel hurts them greatly."

Satan leaned back in his chair as he slumped down. "This... this battle will decide the future. As long as a core group of demons survives, we can greatly devastate the angels, weaken or cripple the gods, and live to fight another day. By burrowing into the Earth and hiding ourselves

for a time, we can expand our fighting numbers quickly. If need be, we can attack the angels again. But eventually, with the angels gone, our only obstacle will be Man."

Bael cackled as he slapped the table. "Gwahahaha! Satan! You have truly outdone yourselves! Of what use would a pure human fighting army be? Without their precious Hero, humans have no ability to fight at all!"

Laughter rippled around the table, but Satan held up his hand and it quickly died off. "No, you underestimate the humans too easily, Bael. Hercules is a once-in-a-generation Hero. We lose to him every time we encounter him on the battlefield. But more importantly, he is a half-blood. He possesses the immortality of the gods, or at least a bit of it. He will easily live for another hundred years, and possibly forever, unless we can kill him off. And even if we do, another may take his place. Humanity... they were no threat at all in the beginning... but I feel that if given time, they may someday be our equals. We have to kill them off before that happens."

Bael stared ahead stonily. "Do you really think humanity could ever pose a threat to us? What can weak little fleshbags do against an army of monsters?"

Satan spoke quietly now, as his eyes darkened. "You won't understand it until you've seen what I've seen, Bael. Humanity is a parasitic lifeform that feeds on other life. If we don't eradicate them, they will eradicate not only us, but the angels too."

Bael nodded, as his gaze lowered.

Part 167:

Zeus glared down at the old man in front of the throne. "Raphael, I find this hard to believe, but I've heard from some very reliable sources that you gave aid to the enemy. You gave them a weapon of considerable power."

Raphael yawned as his eyes glazed over. "Mmm. Indeed I did. What of it?"

Zeus quietly grinded his teeth together. "You... I know you are considered the 'wisest' among us, but that was fairly *stupid*, don't you think?"

A sigh escaped Raphael's mouth as he stared off in the distance. Other angels and gods in the great throne room continued to pretend they weren't listening intently, but anyone could see they were. "My lord, why should you be worried about it? Hercules will, at this rate, eradicate the demons within the next couple of months. You may not be aware of the origins of that orb, but I am. It will make Lucifer go power-hungry and mad with lust for the throne. Once he destroys Satan, he will lead the demons blundering into many battles, making their defeat that much swifter."

Zeus eyed the old man carefully. "You... as the wisest of the archangels, I'm surprised. I'm mostly surprised you expected that weakling of a demon to win in combat against the most battle hardened and highly evolved of their kind. I'm even more surprised that you don't know he was already defeated, even killed, by Satan."

Raphael jerked his head towards the throne. "Hmm? He's dead? But... how? Compared to me, he was weak, but he was highly evolved for a demon. Combining his evolutionary powers with the orb should have made him unstoppable."

Zeus leaned backwards in his chair, resting his body heavily on it. "Nay, he lost decisively. I'm shocked you weren't aware of this... don't you possess the counterpart to the Orb of Death? It should have given you the details of their battle."

Raphael shrugged, as he sat down cross-legged on the floor. "I was too busy to bother watching."

"Too busy? You mean you were too *lazy*." Zeus groaned as he debated what could happen next. "And we have another issue. With Lucifer dead, Satan undoubtedly has the orb in his possession. But ever since Lucifer's death, the *plant* inside the Demon's fortress has gone quiet. I don't have any ability to see what plans they're cooking up next."

"Haa... I guess this means maybe you gods and angels can finally stop calling me the 'wise one'. I'm not as wise and all-knowing as you seem to think." Raphael sighed again as he stared into the distance. "But even with the Orb of Death, even if Satan took every drop of its concentrated power, he'd never be able to defeat the greatest of the gods and angels combined. He's still no threat, and we can bleed him out over time with the humans."

Zeus nodded thoughtfully. "Yes, that would seem to be true, at the least. You made an error, but it appeared to be a small one. Hercules will still be killing millions of demons at every battle. This one loss will not have long term consequences. However... *don't do it again.*" Zeus waved his hand as he dismissed Raphael. Raphael stood up slowly and slightly bowed. "Thank you, King of Gods. I will be going, now."

As Raphael took three steps away from the throne, a messenger cherub flew towards the throne room. "My lord! King of Gods! The demons, they are assaulting Mount Sinai!"

Zeus quickly stood up from his throne. "What?! Assaulting us directly?! Those damned fools! We'll show them the power of Heaven!"

Raphael froze mid-step. *By the gods, this is what Kronos warned Gabriel of.*

He quickly turned back to Zeus. "My liege! Let us temporarily free Gabriel from his detention! He will be able to aid us!"

Zeus sneered. "No! We do not need help from a traitor! We will easily crush the demonic hordes!" He turned to the angels in the room. "Quickly now, all angels to battle! Rally our troops! We cannot rely on the humans in this holy land!"

While everyone else let loose a war cry, Raphael felt a deep cold wash over himself. *It is as I feared... this is the worst situation.*

He quickly righted himself. *I must tell Gabriel, I care not what the King of Gods does to me.*

Part 168: Battle For Heaven

This is it. The most important fight of our lives. This will decide who controls the fate of Earth.

Satan charged behind a wave of millions of demons, as they screamed and raved, tearing through the passages of Sinai. Already, they had killed twenty angels in a flash who had gotten in their way. The meager number of guards for this place, assumed to be impregnable if not undiscoverable, were insufficient for a full-scale demonic invasion.

Demons poured all over the floor, the walls, the ceilings. Skittering and clattering about, making a deafening noise as they charged forwards, a mass of hatred and revenge-seekers coming forth to destroy their eternal oppressors.

Satan did not smile, he did not laugh. This was no time for either. He would lose a lot of his people on this day, but in the process, they would cripple the angels forever. To stalemate a battle so they might win the war? A simple choice.

" Charge! Kill all who get in our way! Kill the weak ones, the generals will take on the real threats! " Satan bellowed at the top of his voice. His words may not have been heard or understood, but their intent was. *Kill them all, even if it costs you your own life.*

Within a few minutes, they had already arrived in the main room that held the Heavenly Gate. A thousand angels had prepared a spell of mass annihilation. As the demons began to swarm into the room, an archangel at the front, Uriel, opened his mouth to give the order. *Fire.*

But he was unable to. His head slowly fell from his body, as Satan appeared in the shadow behind him, his arm transforming into a battle scythe as it detached the archangel's head from his body. In the blink of an eye, a mighty archangel was felled before he had the chance to react.

Shadowstep. An ability that Satan had consumed from the corpse of Lucifer. One of Satan's most potent abilities had been awakened by Leviathan. The Unique class ability, *Consume*. The ability to take the powers of any foe he killed in battle. As a result of his last meeting with Leviathan, his powers would only now truly begin to awaken.

Satan, the Great Devourer, as he would be called after this battle.

As Uriel's head fell, the other angels jerked back in alarm at the sudden appearance of the demon in their midst. In a flash, Satan had unleashed his mightiest ability, the Ultimate Attack, knocking many angels out of their spell-stance, or killing them outright.

Feeble, I expected more of these holy beings. Satan grimaced as he dashed forwards, spinning his body like a horizontal cyclone, and plowing right through the center of an angel. The angel's body, now having a gaping hole in it, collapsed to the ground seconds later.

As Satan killed more and more angels, he began to feel more powers inside his body. *Interesting, perhaps if I kill some more strong ones and quickly adjust to these new powers, this won't be an actual stalemate today.*

After the thousand angels in the room were brutally killed with minimal losses, Satan quickly charged through the portal to Heaven, and his minions began flowing through it as well.

In the room they had entered, it was pure white. No shadows existed, as the light appeared to come from every surface and ceiling and the sky as well. The light was impossible to shadow-step through.

But Satan didn't need it. Using the invisible limbs he had grown, which enabled him to fight opponents with the elements of surprise, he found himself propelled around by his limbs, allowing himself to move unnaturally and unexpectedly, which helped him confuse and overwhelm his opponents.

As his minions entered the room, quickly filling it up with their kind, they continued racing outside of it, to the great empty white expanse of heaven.

All around him, he saw clouds. They looked to be unsuitable for walking on, yet he was surrounded by a few million angels, with scatterings of gods and demigods here and there. They walked or floated, all of them spread out in a circular fashion. Satan grimaced. *There's more than I expected.*

"Charge! Today, we bring an end to the evil angels that have wrought so much pain on us!" His minions roared with delight as they charged out of the exit and through the small door, resembling the fast pouring stream of a faucet that would be invented millennia later.

* * *

The battle was intense. The angels were able to harness their combined power to keep blasting weakened, yet effective versions of Gabriel's holy light attack, slaying dozens, even hundreds of demons for each wave they fired. Yet, the angels were beginning to weaken. Their seemingly infinite numbers were depleting rapidly, as were Satan's minions. He was busy fighting with the god of thunder and thus could not keep track of the numbers, but their numbers were reaching near parity.

Thor grimaced as another mighty blow from Satan caught him off guard. *Invisible arms, maybe ten of them, they can pass through sometimes and other times they harden. Truly*

impossible to deal with. Thor bellowed as heavenly lightning shot down at the speed of light towards Satan. However, the light was so bright that for a split second, it made a shadow appear behind Thor, which Satan shadow-stepped towards. The lightning missed completely, but Satan did not.

In a flash, he brought his knife around, plunging it deep into Thor's back, directly into his heart. Thor gasped, as Satan spoke. "Unworthy." With a quick wrench, Satan twisted the knife, splitting Thor's heart in half. Yanking it out quickly, Satan moved on towards a female goddess, Diana, leaving Thor to fall forward, his body slumped in death.

Diana, the Goddess of the Hunt, wielded a mighty bow that could shoot arrows at incredible speeds. Before she could nock her first arrow and aim it at Satan, he quickly used his newest stolen power. "Lightning, thunder, hear my cry!" With a massive blast, powerful lightning rained from the sky, smiting Diana in an instant.

Satan quickly looked around, noting the troop disparities. He still held a 1.5 to 1 troop ratio advantage, but it had been nearly 7 to 1 in the beginning. As he had first expected, it would not end so easily.

The battle had dragged on for hours, and now he could see that a group of his top generals were fighting a massive god, one who moved at truly godlike speeds. Only one could keep up with him at all, and that was Belial.

She was definitely losing though. Belial fought Zeus, the King of Gods. Zeus had the ability to move at the speed of light, as best as Satan could tell. He moved so fast, it almost appeared to be a variant of shadow-stepping. However, he was a massive target since he was at full titan size. "If that fool had an ounce of sense, he'd have shrunk himself down and condensed his power. He must think himself invincible."

Satan had already figured out who most of the combatants were on the battlefield. By stealing the powers of the ones he killed, he was also able to steal a portion of their recent memories. He could, in a flash, identify the major gods and demigods at a glance, as well as a goodly number of angels.

Where is Gabriel? Satan wondered to himself, as he used his invisible appendages to blast forwards at Zeus. *It seems strange that he would not be here, unleashing his cosmic power on us. What sort of trickery have they in store for us?*

Before he could get to Zeus, a challenger leaped in front of him. A massive demigod, one he had seen far too many times as of late.

Satan sneered at the being in front of him, one almost exactly the same size as himself. *Hercules.*

Part 169: Fated

Satan stared ahead at the man before him. Physically, he appeared to be 35 years of age, but as a demi-human, looks could be deceiving.

A terrible bright yellow aura rippled off his body. And... in his left hand, he held a fantastically bright orb. "Devil, leader of the demonic race, this will be as far as you go today. I will put an end to you, and kill all of your kind."

Satan eyed the bright white orb. "The Beacon of Life, eh? The gods must be serious about this to trust a mere demigod with it. Even with its power though, do you think yourself invincible?"

The demigod's eyes narrowed as his jawline set itself. "Not invincible, but strong enough... strong enough to kill *you*."

Satan chuckled quietly. "Kukuku... a child playing with a weapon he knows nothing of. But you know... I've already defeated a wielder of the Orb of Death, do not think that this will be enough to stop me."

Hercules twitched, as he suddenly rushed at Satan, his right fist moving with uncanny speed. Without saying a word, his punch smashed into Satan's jaw, sending him spinning rapidly as he tumbled sideways through the clouds. Hercules charged again, this time pulling out a flail with a spiked ball and chain attached. He swung it towards the spot that Satan was at, but missed as Satan's invisible limbs pulled him out of the way. To Hercules, it appeared almost as if Satan had simply been yanked out of the way by an invisible force.

He quickly glanced around. *Does he have an ally with telekinesis nearby?*

Before he could finish the thought Satan righted himself with an odd movement, and dashed towards Hercules, his body erratically moving left to right, as if being pulled along by multiple unseen forces. Hercules yanked back his flail and swung it around himself in circles, but it was a slow and clunky weapon, easily evaded by the swift demon.

The demon lord once again called thunder down from the skies, as the blast arced itself at the metal flail in Hercules' hand, causing him to drop it and stagger back in pain. "Bastard!" Hercules quickly shook it off though, as he healed himself using the Beacon in his hand.

The devil pulled himself towards Hercules, one of his invisible limbs grabbing onto Hercules and causing the man to stagger forwards as something unexpectedly gripped him. *What the hell*

was that?! Hercules swiped at the weight on his shoulder, but his hand passed through whatever was there.

Satan grinned evilly as his eyes flashed red. *What's this? The Hero seems to be confused!* He jammed another of his limbs into the ground, as the one attached to Hercules yanked the demigod at Satan with tremendous force. The movement caught Hercules off guard as he stumbled forwards. Before Satan could get close enough to finish off the youth, an arrow blasted into his own chest, causing Satan to stagger forwards in pain. Hercules grabbed into the ground, jamming his foot down to stop his momentum.

He quickly glanced backwards to see Diana, the one he had thought he killed in a single blow, nocking another arrow as she aimed at him. However, now that he knew it was coming, the instant she fired the arrow, one of his limbs intercepted it in midair, smacking it harmlessly out of the way. An expression of shock passed over her face. "Mother of Hera! How in the gods-?!"

Satan quickly turned back to Hercules as his hands cast a spell, granting defensive autonomy to two of his invisible limbs. They would protect him from threats without him having to do anything else. *It's okay, eight more limbs is still a large number to fight with.*

He glanced down at the arrow rammed into his gut. *She's a worthless shot, she missed my heart by inches and only nicked a lung, I can still fight with this. If she were a demon of mine, I'd behead her for being so pathetic.*

Satan had one small problem, however. He lacked healing abilities. Or at least, he *had* lacked them. One of the angels appeared to have a remarkably strong healing ability that he quickly discovered in his mind. *Perfect.* Using one of his immaterial limbs, he reached around, yanking the arrow out in an instant, as his regular arms healed himself.

A quick thought came to his mind, as his arm held the arrow, he gave it a light flick, sending it flying at Diana. In an instant, before she could even react, it impaled her in the head, killing her instantly. *She'd better not get up from that one.*

Hercules watched in horror, as Diana was killed by a single stray thought from the demon in front of him. *This monster! I have to defeat him, at any cost!*

Hercules pulled a rock out of his pocket, a small thing, weighing only a few ounces, just big enough to fit into the palm of his hand. With his unbelievable strength, he hurled it at Satan's chest. The rock flew forwards at three times the speed of sound, bridging the fifty foot gap or so in an instant, but it somehow was deflected by something unseen, flying off to the side, missing Satan by inches, and smashing through the cloud cover in the distance, ending in a resounding *BOOM.*

Satan chuckled. "Is that it, *boy*? Throwing rocks? Swinging your big chain around? A bit of punching, even? You're just a big strongman brute. Even your colossal strength, far dwarfing mine, is no match for me if you can't hit me with it. What is with you strong-man types and never using your head?"

In the blink of an eye, Satan was in front of Hercules, as the demigod gasped in surprise. He tried to rear back to swing his fist, but his strength suddenly vanished, as something appeared inside his chest, ripping his heart out before he could even see it.

His heart floated in front of him, in midair, as he fell to his knees.

"As all of them have been, you were *unworthy*." Satan sneered as the youth slumped in front of him.

Hercules, feeling his last moments were upon him, did something unexpected.

He laughed.

"Ha... haha... you demonic fool... kuh... haha... I am the first of many. The ritual is already complete... when I die... my spirit will pass on... I will haunt you even in death... kuh haha...."

Satan grimaced. "Laughing at me as you die, eh? Enjoy the chuckle. I'm going to kill your daddy now."

With a single movement, Satan crushed Hercules' head in his hands.

The first Hero, savior of mankind, wielder of the Sacred Light, Hercules, was dead.

Part 170:

Zeus watched in horror, with his incredible perception of time, as his son was completely and utterly defeated by Satan. He had always warned his son that he fought best when he had his troops with him. The powers that he had made him invincible against lower intelligence foes, and his special ability allowed him to direct and command lower minded humans, but without his troops, he was only 1/10th the fighter he could be.

His son's head was crushed into a bloody mess, and suddenly, something horrible happened, *all of the demons at once* started coordinating their attacks like never before. While they were being felled left and right before, and now the troops were scaled 1 to 1 ratio, the million or so troops left on the angel's side suddenly started falling at terrifying rates, as the demons started moving in a completely coordinated manner... almost as if...

"Hahahaha!!! So THIS is the unique power your son held?! The ability to mentally link with all troops that were under his command!!" Satan cackled maniacally, as his troops started magically evading blows they shouldn't have seen coming, stretching their limbs around in ways that defied the imagination, and suddenly completely dominating the battlefield.

"What in the name of the Titans is this heresy?!" Zeus bellowed, as fifty demons of assorted types leaped at him. In an instant, using his incredible speed, he beheaded all of them, but he was mighty, ten tiers above his regular troops and even the few remaining archangels and gods. They had no chance.

He gasped as three powerful demigods were torn to shreds in front of him, in less than a second. The demons almost seemed to be in a blood frenzy, so great was their power.

"Th-this is... a total rout?!" Zeus watched in horror as hundreds of angels were being butchered every second, and the demons were suddenly taking next to no losses. Satan grinned evilly at him.

"It's my win, you disgusting fiend." Satan reared up on his invisible limbs and launched himself at Zeus.

And suddenly, *chaos*.

A massive blast of light erupted from the back of the battlefield, far off in the distance, as Gabriel's titanic form suddenly appeared over the horizon. It completely killed a hundred thousand, perhaps two hundred thousand demons in a single blast. Zeus gasped as he witnessed the awesome power of the Holy Beam of Heavenly Destruction.

It passed through the forces of the light, but de-materialized the forces of dark at the atomic level. Even if they had the ability to regenerate from a single remaining cell, nothing was left. It wiped them so cleanly off the face of the universe, one would be hard pressed to prove they had ever existed.

Satan's breath caught in his throat as he once again bore witness to the colossal power of the Cosmic angel. Ordering his troops with reckless abandon, he ordered them to attack the archangel at once. If they could kill him, the battle would surely be theirs.

Even as his minions charged at Gabriel, who was preparing another massive blast, the angels and gods could scarcely land a single blow on the demons that totally ignored them, so great was the new power Hercules had accidentally gifted to the demons.

Gabriel, still charging the attack for another wave, realized the demons would be upon him in seconds. He would not have enough time to charge it and fire at them. Just then, he heard a voice in his mind.

Fear not, brother. The forces of justice shall win on this day.

From high in the sky, a massive dragon, a creature of the light appeared. It was the holiest angel, converted into his purest form. *Michael*. The Divine King. In his purest form, he possessed power equal to, and possibly even rivaling that of his counterpart, Gabriel. He could only maintain his form a short while, but unlike Gabriel, he required no charging times for his attack.

"*Dragon's Cleansing Flame of Heaven!*" Michael blasted a huge wave of light energy out of his mouth, eradicating several thousand troops that were nearly on Gabriel in one shot. An instant later, he fired again, after taking a deep breath. Each time he fired, he seemed to absorb the light throughout all of heaven into his very soul, causing the whiteness of the place to dim for a second.

Satan staggered back as he gasped in horror. *Damn! This battle is not winnable, even now!*

At that instant, Gabriel's shot was ready to fire. He grinned as he targeted the Devil himself. "Goodbye, Satan."

BOOM!

A blast of holy light, moving too quickly to perceive, shot at Satan. He was instantly destroyed, so quickly that he almost seemed to vanish before it even hit him.

His minions screamed in horror, as they scattered in disarray, easily being picked off, one by one. His generals, seeing their leader had gone to the void, quickly gave the retreat order, fleeing heaven.

Within a few minutes, it was all over.

Zeus collapsed to the ground, staring at the horrifying mess of bodies of demons, angels, and gods all around him. "Can this... be called a win?"

On that day, over 5 million angels and gods were slain. 34 million or more demons were also slain.

Thus ended the War for Heaven. But which side had won? Even Zeus and the archangels could not figure it out for a long time.

* * *

Satan gasped, as he reappeared outside the portal, back in the entrance of Mount Sinai. "Great ghost of sin! That was a close one!"

Barbatos nodded. "I watched through your eyes as you commanded, and pulled you back at the last second. They will surely think you dead."

Satan nodded. "Get the others here too. Start with the highest ranking officers, especially Belial and Diablo, and then work your way down. Quickly!"

His senior demon grinned. "My liege, you must think me stupid. I already did. Look behind you!"

Satan gasped as he whipped around a hundred of his best generals were alive, but...

Satan paused. "The Beacon of Life! Did we recover it?"

Belial grimaced. "My liege, it was my duty, but... I was engaged in combat with Zeus himself. Forgive me, but I was spared no chance to obtain it."

Satan nodded. "It is fine. It was a secondary objective. We completed the main goal. Now let's get out of here, before they have a chance to find out that I am alive."

The others nodded quickly. They had lost more than 99% of their entire military, but that was fine. In fact, it was their plan the entire time. As an added bonus, their leader, chosen by the Hand of Death that guided the monsters and demons of the world itself, had gained far more power on that day.

They would be back, and next time, they would not be able to lose.

Part 171: Aftermath

Zeus breathed heavily, as his heart slowed down. He rubbed his forehead, but realized his hands were covered in blood. He was smearing the blood of fallen comrades and enemies all over himself, but in the end, he did not care.

He stared bitterly at the friends and comrades he had lost. Truth be told, having only recently ascended as King of Gods, he did not know most of them, but he knew some.

And... Hercules... Zeus fought back tears as his son, the most powerful demigod he had helped create, lied on the ground, his head crushed in such a way that he would not have been identifiable if Zeus had not witnessed his death personally.

Zeus numbly walked over to his son's body, bending down and cradling him in his arms. "M... my boy... I..." No longer able to contain his tears, he silently wept as warm liquids came pouring out of his eyes.

This is so unfair. I can't... I can't call this a win... this was a draw, at best...

Gabriel, now shrunk down to Zeus' size, also stared numbly at the battlefield. Michael had already reformed himself in his normal angelic form and left, not wishing to gaze upon the devastation any longer. Gabriel looked around but could not find Uriel, the King of Justice. *Ah... right. He was in the vanguard. He was supposed to obliterate the enemy before they could even enter the portal. Their arrival here would mean that... he was likely slain.*

Naturally, with millions of bodies, they would not find his for a long time, but since he did not appear to be among the remaining thousands of angels and gods...

Gabriel heaved a large sigh as his shoulders sagged. *Thousands.* That's how many were left. There had been millions, before. *Kronos was right.* Gabriel thought to himself bitterly. *We should have sealed the Gate to Heaven. We left an open door for them to invade us.*

He glanced over at Zeus and saw the Titan sobbing his heart out, with the body of his son in his arms, a gory mess covering his entire body. Gabriel felt his stare waver as he couldn't bear to look. *A private moment must not be interrupted. We have all lost someone... on this day.*

The cleanup would have to wait. The angels and gods that remained, a few thousand at best, crammed themselves into the largest room of the main palace, barring the throne room itself: the great Dining Hall. It was a massive room, made of marble, gold, and silver, as all buildings of Heaven were. It was covered in fine art, rich tapestries, and one of the walls had a massive

bookshelf that contained thousands of scrolls, written by angels, archangels, gods, and demihumans alike, all for the purpose of remembering the history of the universe, as it were.

But nobody in the room cared about the fancy tapestries, or the beautiful varnished furniture... they all sat in the rows of the tables, staring ahead blankly. They did not require sustenance, but they usually enjoyed the taste of food, as it were.

Today however, Zeus and Gabriel, still the same size as each other, sat across from each other on opposite sides of the room, as the remaining denizens of Heaven gathered together to discuss what they must do next.

Gabriel broke the silence. "My liege, great god, Zeus. I regret saying this... I regret it with all my being. There is something that I spoke of with Kronos, shortly before his passing. Something of monumental importance. In fact, it was so important, that I dared not say it during your trial that you gave me, for fear it may leak to the demons. But it appears my efforts were futile. The demons discovered the information I held somehow. I know not how, but they did."

Zeus felt his temper flaring, as the memories of his son came rushing back. "...Information? *Explain.* " His voice was very non-subtly tinged with anger, as fire seemed to shoot from his ears. "If you *know* something, you had better say it now."

Gabriel looked around at the remaining angels and gods in the room. *Because I did not speak sooner, we suffered an overwhelming loss of life. I... don't deserve to even live at this point.* "My liege, it is with regards to exactly what transpired today. Kronos explained an important truth to me, about why he never took steps to eradicate the demons, nor to give the humans an overwhelming advantage. And... this deals with the reason he forced me to stop your son from winning battles so easily..."

Zeus leaned forwards in his chair, resting his elbows on his legs, and his chin on his clasped hands, as he could feel his body starting to shake slightly with anger. " *Go... on...* " He bit the words off icily, clearly very angry about these late revelations.

Gabriel took a deep breath and began to explain.

* * *

An hour passed, and Gabriel concluded. "Thusly, we need the humans for their thought energy, but if the demons are truly defeated, humans will have no reason to fearfully pray to us, keeping us alive. Further, if the demons die, and we are the only beings left aside from humanity, they will grow to envy us, and eventually come to kill us... assuming the lack of prayers doesn't do the job."

Zeus sighed deeply, as he sagged back in the chair. "I... I can't be angry anymore. I feel.... nothing... nothing at all. If you had told me this sooner... perhaps we could have-"

The archangel raised his hand and interrupted. "No! My liege, I will accept any punishment for my actions. However, while this was beyond regretful considering the devastation we have faced, I feel it would have happened anyway. If the information had leaked fully to the demons, they might now be trying to kill the humans to further weaken us."

Gabriel paused to take a breath, and before he could respond, Raphael spoke from among the crowd. "My brothers, my friends, my dear king, if I may be allowed, I would like to offer... an idea."

Zeus slowly glanced down at the small old man speaking. "...Go on, at this point, your wisdom can only help."

The old man sighed. *Again with the 'wisdom', when will they ever stop?* "My liege, an idea came to me while Gabriel spoke... perhaps, a way to survive, while maintaining the status quo. We need to go back to doing what we did before. Even with Satan dead, another demon will take control, and they will eventually return. We still need humans to fight them, more now than ever before. I propose a bold plan, if you would wish to hear it."

Zeus nodded tiredly. "Yes, yes, go on. Just say it already." *I wish to be gone from this place so I may bury my son among the fallen of Valhalla.*

The man quickly nodded. "Yes, of course. As I see it, we absolutely must close the gate to Heaven, or relocate. I believe that we can work from the shadows, instead of out in the open. Instead of aiding mankind on the battlefield, we will help them grow to new powers so they may combat the demons themselves. We will forcefully evolve the humans via new types of weaponry, and try to create or teach new champions that will advance them forwards. We will do this without openly showing ourselves. But, we must also instill a new sort of worship among the humans, and this is where it gets tricky."

Gabriel leaned in, as he listened intently to Raphael's explanation. "We made a mistake, by trying to unite humanity together. We need humans to not only fight the demons, but fight amongst themselves. This way, they will not only keep the demons from expanding too greatly, but also develop new weaponry in times of peace. Further, instead of one shared religion, I propose breaking them up, making humans worship different gods and whatnot. By doing so, we will further divide humans, and this leads up to the final goal."

Raphael waved his hands dramatically. "Let's assume that somehow humans gain the power to kill all of the demons *for good*. If that were to happen, they would turn on us in an instant, if they learned of our existence. But even if they don't, with a single shared religion, and no

demons as enemies, humans would quickly abandon their prayers to us, which would result in the death of the angels, even if not the gods themselves. By giving the religions meaning beyond slaying demons, we can incite holy wars to keep the population of humanity thinned, just as they thin the demons, and in doing so, we will not die out so easily."

The room grew silent as everyone quietly pondered his suggestion. *He is so wise, some thought. A true leader uses wisdom to guide the angels. He should be at the right hand, if not the highest seat of the Gods.*

Zeus paused, those same thoughts crossing through his head. "Cultivating new religions, split religions? It seems far-fetched, yet... I can think of no better solution, not even one that compares. Raphael, as always, your wisdom is overwhelming. I will overlook mistakes that you have made as of late. This is clearly the only solution that I can see working, unless any others here wish to offer their own ideas."

Obviously, no others in the room wished to contradict the Wisdom King. Raphael sighed. *It seemed obvious to me, I don't think it's foolproof anyway, and it has one major downside, though it's best not to mention it right now. We need a solution, and fast. We'll work out the kinks as we go.*

Zeus and Gabriel nodded as they both rose. Zeus raised his hand as he spoke. "All in favor, raise your hand, and say 'aye'."

The entire room unanimously agreed. The new goal, Project Revelations, was underway.

Part 172:

Satan quietly paced in front of his remaining few hundred minions and generals. Counting the ones he had left behind to guard the main fortress (who would inevitably be useless against anything but a small skirmish force of humans), he had far less than a thousand demons left. Luckily, the ones that remained were his most powerful generals.

We can easily replace the weaklings and poorly evolved ones over time. It's the advanced ones with high intelligence I'd hate to lose. Satan felt his eyes glaze over as he looked at all the remaining demons under his control.

"Let's get to it." Satan sat down on the floor, his back to the entrance of the fortress, as his other minions and generals sat facing him. "I have decided that we have two ways to proceed, and I need input on what you all think would be the best approach."

Diablo and the others nodded. "My lord, if it is your order, we will follow it no matter what."

"Good. So here is the first plan; we can simply hide underground, amassing forces for a very long time, and letting the humans evolve as they please. Over time, the humans will likely become indifferent towards demons, due to the humans' poor memory and short lifespans, and as they forget about us, they will focus on the angels above them. However, if we let humans kill the angels off, that would likely mean the humans are highly advanced and will be a major threat to us."

The lord of demons took a sip of some leftover blood wine from the pantries before he continued. "The second plan works like this; we still go into hiding, popping out occasionally to terrorize the humans, but only in small groups. Give the humans a threat to worry about, make them advance quickly so they can take out the archangels and gods themselves, but also try and keep the humans thinned out where possible so we still have the advantage in numbers."

Belial lazily flicked her eyes back and forth. "It seems a sound plan either way. However, the first idea seems very... *boring*. I love ripping human men limb from limb, after I have a bit of fun with them, you know?"

As he bobbed his head from side to side, Diablo nodded. "I believe the angels will be forced to go into hiding. They will likely close the Gate to Heaven at some point, likely very soon, so that their holy ground cannot be invaded."

"I agree." Barbatos chimed in. "The angels will be no threat to us for a long while, and if we hide underground, they will have no way to kill us. Our biggest advantage is that they hopefully think they've killed our commander off, so they may underestimate our remaining power."

As he listened to their thoughts, another idea popped in to Satan's mind. "You know... the angels and gods have their own domain, so why don't we try and find a way to make our own?"

Most of the other demons, sans Belial, seemed confused. "What do you mean? Is burrowing deep into the Earth and taking control of the underground not exactly that?" Bael spoke up for the first time.

"No, I'm talking about creating an entirely new 'space' outside of Earth. I do not know how the angels and gods did it, but..." Satan paused as a certain being entered his mind. "...I think I know of one who might have the power to help us create such a place."

Barbatos looked past his leader, at the outside world. "So it appears to be settled, then. We will, on occasion, exit the underground to terrorize the humans, but for the most part we will focus on increasing our numbers exponentially, and building a whole new space for our people outside Earth. Is that the gist of it?"

Satan nodded as he grinned. "Yes. We have suffered much. Even if it takes a thousand years, ten thousand years, or a million years.... we will win this war by way of attrition. Unlike our two enemies, time is on our side. We can afford to be patient and wait, but they cannot."

The demons cheered and whooped and hollered as they got up and went their own ways, to grab whatever they needed before they began burrowing into the Earth to create their new space.

As for their new space... it would later become known to humans, angels, and gods as *Hell*.

Part 173:

Satan and Belial stood together in the dark, as they faced their patriarch, the father of the demonic military's might, Leviathan.

Leviathan, now having a third person who knew of his existence (Though he had been informed of the killing of Lucifer) had seemed to be growing restless as of late. He tired of being stuck underground.

" ...Satan. For too long you have pretended to release me from this place. I have waited for over a hundred years as you failed to bring me proof of the excavation... and now you seek my power again? Do you think me a fool? "

Satan and Belial bowed before him. "My liege... I will admit that as of now, we have not taken any steps to free you..." Satan spoke hesitantly. "But, I realize now that I was in error to not do so. My people need your power now more than ever."

The great dragon rose up to his full height as he heaved a mighty sigh; black flames spouted from his mouth as he exhaled deeply. **" Satan, I have given you vast powers, a keen intellect, minions to control, and the ability to fight and kill your oppressors. Yet still, you have not given me the one thing I desire. Why should I help you this time? "**

Satan paused, as he thought of a hasty response. "I... have no real answer. I just need your power to create a safe space for my kind, in our own dimension of sorts. After that, I will be able to free you from this prison."

The dragon sneered. **" Lies. Always the lies... I will do you one last favor. I will give you the power that you seek, but if you should come here again, if you should think of taking more of my power without holding up your end of the bargain, I will bring you a swift death. Now... take it and BEGONE! "**

The dragon's eyes glowed pure white for a second as he transferred a miniscule amount of his power to the puny demons below him. Their bodies almost exploded, due to how much energy he had given. They writhed on the floor in agony, and yet eternal bliss, as their powers grew exponentially.

After a few minutes, they stood up again. Satan was now a High Devil, and Belial had evolved into something... wholly unseen before, completely unique.

They both quickly bowed, and thanked the black dragon. "When next we see you, we will be sure to free you. I promise you that."

The dragon waved his front paw at Satan. " **Get out.** "

* * *

Horses neighed in the distance, as the small child ran for her life. *They killed mommy and papa, they're monsters!*

It had been a few weeks since demons reappeared, ransacking her small village, as the militia were called into action to fight back. Swinging their swords and shovels, they managed to beat back the monsters, but at the cost of many lives.

The young child had managed to survive, but her mother was slain by a scyther, and her father had lashed out in anger, killing the demon with his bare hands. It was an unbelievable feat of strength that earned him praise from the village.

But without his beloved wife, the man didn't care. He only had his one daughter left, both of her brothers were at war with the people of the East, and the village was attacked daily by their raiders.

Babylon. A rising city in the north-east, which had seized upon several means of expanding its population and growing its military. They sent raiders, professional military units, and other such things to attack and cow the surrounding areas into submission.

One of those units had finally destroyed her home, and her father was slain in his bed. Only by hiding and fleeing had the child managed to escape their wrath.

Tears pouring down her face, she hurriedly raced towards a nearby mountain range, covered in tall grass and trees, a thick forest cover protected her from view. But the riders in the distance knew they had not killed everyone in the city. They had seen a single child escape, and their orders were to kill and burn everyone alive in the name of the great Nur-Adad, ruler of Babylonia.

The child fled as the horses drew near. They had to search with their eyes, as tamed wolves were not available to any yet but the rich and wealthy. The child cowered in fear as she reached a sheer wall of rock, her escape totally cut off. *No... no they're going to find and kill me... just like they did my mommy and papa...*

She chanced upon a strange spot in the wall, where a heap of rocks seemed to have been piled there in a pathetic effort to cover up a passageway. Quickly pulling them out of the way, her heart leaped for joy as she discovered there was a hole hidden there. Yanking the rocks out of the way, she climbed in, closing it up behind her.

The men outside were yelling something in their native tongue, one she could not understand. But she did notice that the voices seemed to be getting closer. Her small body easily fitting inside the large tunnel, she quickly made her way deep down inside, leaving the voices behind her.

It's dark... I'm scared... I can't see a thing! The girl thought to herself, as she quickly but carefully moved down the tunnel. It appeared to constrict the further she went, but her body was still small enough to fit. The voices were finally so distant she couldn't hear them any longer, but she still kept climbing down. *I will likely be killed and eaten by a bear, but so long as it is not those demons or those people outside, I will not care!*

Finally, she stumbled into what felt like a much more open room. She could see nothing as it was wholly pitch black inside the room, but her heart thumped in her chest. *She was not alone.*

"Is... is... someone... there?" Her voice almost cracked as she squeaked in a timid tone.

At first, nothing happened. Then she felt a quiet rumbling, as something ahead of her, *something massive*, seemed to rumble only a few yards away.

And then, that something *spoke*. A deep, thunderous voice, one that appeared to speak quietly, as if to match her volume, yet it contained an ominous edge to it.

" Hmm? You are neither Satan, nor Belial. Certainly not Lucifer. What is your name? "

The little girl, hearing this monstrous voice, yet not one filled with animosity, strangely felt her fear dissipate. "My name... it's Amelia. Amelia Greyheart."

Part 174: Innocence

Amelia stared into the darkness, wondering who she was talking to. Her eyes could not adjust to the total lack of light, but she could almost see a big beast of some sort shifting around, as if he were too large for this room.

"What's your name? I told you mine, so you have to tell me yours!" The girl brazenly spoke into the darkness, oblivious to the dark terror that lay in front of her.

" Kekeke... you would order me to reveal my name? I wonder, how fearless would you be if you knew my true form, hmm? " Saying that, Leviathan reared up and sat on his back legs, pushing his body up against the ceiling with his front. Igniting his eyes and reversing the flow of the darkness that poured out of him, he managed to brighten up the cavern around him ever so slightly, just enough for the child to get a look at him. **" I am LEVIATHAN, the King of all Darkness, the last of the dragons of old! "**

The little girl stared up at him in awe. "Wow! You're so big! Why are you living in this tiny little cave though?"

Leviathan, still reared up on his legs, paused. *Hmm? Why is she not cowering in fear at my very presence? Why are her knees not shaking in fright knowing that her end is near?*

" Child, do you not understand the situation you are in? You're standing there, asking questions of a mighty dragon, one who would surely eat you in an instant! "

Amelia stared up at him quizzically. "You will? Why haven't you then?"

Leviathan, about to retort, found himself unable to. *Why? Why haven't I?*

" I... you... you would not be much of a snack! I have eaten thousands of adventurers who entered my cave, looking for treasure, only to find their fortunes turn into misfortune, when they met ME! " Leviathan snorted, as a massive gout of black flame blasted upwards, hitting the ceiling and dissipating harmlessly.

Amelia plopped her butt on the ground as she sat in a cross legged position, fanning her skirt over herself to look modest, just as her father and mother had always told her to do. "Hmm. I don't know, this cave was kind of out of the way, you know? How have thousands of adventurers entered it when it's so hard to find? And if you ate them, what did you do with their armor and weapons?"

The dragon was silent for a few moments as he stared at the child. *This one, she is not like the humans that I remember from before I was trapped, and certainly not like the ones Satan*

has told me of. There's... something about this one.

" Young one, how old are you? "

She pulled out her fingers to count. "I don't know, maybe um... nine or ten summers?"

The dragon quietly softened his glow as he rumbled to the ground again, the light in the cave vanishing once more. **" I see. More importantly, why do you not fear me? "**

Amelia giggled. "Why should I? You're down here all alone, all by yourself, with nobody to talk to. If you wanted to eat me, you would have done it already. I think you're just... lonely."

The dragon closed his eyes. **" Lonely... perhaps. I've been in this cave for... a long time. I cannot escape, due to magic that holds me here. I have not seen another of my kind since the Great Cataclysm that sealed me here, tens of millions of years ago. Lonely... perhaps I am. "**

The little girl's smile disappeared, as she got up to walk towards the dragon. He did not move as she stumbled towards him in the dark. She fell forwards, and her hand touched his nose. "Oh! I'm sorry! I didn't mean to-"

The dragon felt a strange emotion overcome him. **" No... it is fine. I do not mind. "**

Amelia put her hand back on his nose, then leaned in and hugged his face, her entire body barely stretching from one side of his nose to the other. "Do... you want to be my friend? Do you want a friend?"

The dragon stared at the child. **" A friend? Why would you want to befriend a dragon? "**

The girl let go and sat on the ground, mere inches from his mouth, filled with thousands of razor sharp teeth. "Well... it's not like I have any friends. Those bad men killed my papa. And the demons killed my mommy. But the angels gave the orders to kill... I... I hate all of them."

She stared down forlornly, as images of her papa's bloodied corpse came to her mind. She had watched from under the bed as the bad men impaled him with their long wooden spears. Papa had stared at his daughter under the bed, as the light left his eyes, and his soul left this world.

Leviathan stared at the little girl, who was totally unafraid of him. **" If... if you want a friend... I will be your friend. "**

Suddenly, Leviathan's ears perked up. A noise had appeared further up inside the passage she had come from. It sounded like many footsteps were approaching. Leviathan felt something boil up inside himself. *Anger.*

Those filthy insects wish to hurt my friend. This is... not acceptable...

" Go to the side of the room, child. I think the bad men are coming. "

* * *

Amelia watched from the side of the room, as ten men crawled in. Her eyes had somehow acclimated to the darkness. She could make out their body movements vaguely, though not very well. But strangely, she could make out Leviathan much more easily. It was almost as if she had somehow formed a bond with him.

The men whispered to one another as they entered the room. Their hands grasped the swords at their sides, but they seemed visibly unnerved.

Leviathan spoke to them, causing their bodies to go numb.

" Who disturbs my slumber? "

The front man, apparently the leader, croaked out in a language Amelia could only somewhat understand. "Ah! Monster! We not come for harm! We look for small child! No mean hurt you!"

The dragon formed a tiny smile on his face. **" You think yourself capable of... *hurting me?* Amusing. But... trying to hurt my friend, the one known as the Princess of Darkness, a title bestowed upon her by myself... you will not escape with your lives. "**

In a flash, his head shot forwards, and he chomped and bit at the men, allowing a single one to flee the hole. The others were eviscerated in an instant. Their bodies lay in pieces on the ground.

Amelia started to walk towards their bodies, but Leviathan stopped her. **" No, child. This scene is not suitable for one as young as you. "**

Amelia ignored him as she walked over to the bodies. "I've seen enough... killing. I'm glad. You killed them for me, didn't you? I hate these men. I hate them all! They killed papa! I don't want them to live!"

The dragon watched as the girl first appeared to be angry, and then kneeled down as tears flowed out of her. *How dare the humans do this to an innocent girl. How... dare they...*

" Child. Is there anything that you fear in this world? "

The girl shook her head.

" Death? "

She shook her head again, as she wiped her tears away.

" Pain? Torture? Demons? Angels? Humans? "

Again she shook her head furiously. "No! I'm not afraid! I just hate them! I hate them all!"

Leviathan chuckled quietly to himself. **" Good. Fear will weaken you too much. I have an offer to make you. I would never make this offer to anyone whom I did not consider my closest ally. "**

The little girl turned to the dragon. "What offer, Leviathan?"

" I wish to escape this place. Aside from slowly digging out a pathway big enough for me, there are only a few other ways I could escape, and almost all of them are blocked off by the seal on this place. But... there is one last way. "

The girl almost leaped for joy. "If I can help you get out, I'll do anything! We're friends so that means if you help me, I help you!"

The dragon smiled. **" This is unique. But I know without asking that you would do it in an instant. You are truly... worthy. "**

The dragon reached his paw forwards, leaving it a foot away from her. **" If you wish to crush the humans, the demons, and the angels alike, touch my paw, and say the magic word. "**

Amelia immediately reached over and touched his paw, giggling while she did so. "Okay! What's the word?"

Leviathan sneered as a brilliant grin crossed his face. **" Merge. "**

* * *

A small army followed the lone messenger who had stumbled into the palace screaming and ranting about a monster under a mountain. Being the only surviving member of his troop, the general of the local army immediately issued a command to go search the area and see if he had lied and stabbed his comrades in the back or if he spoke truth. The man begged them to not force him back, but he was forced to lead them back there.

For a full day, they scoured the area, finally arriving upon a small girl sitting in a small clearing, all by herself. The man pointed, terrified, at an opening behind the girl. "The cave! It's there! It's there!!!" He seemed to be almost going out of his mind, but the commanding officer kicked him in the rump and sent him falling to the ground.

"Shut up, worm!" He dismounted his horse and approached the little girl, his sword drawn and aimed at her. "Child, what know you of the cave, hmm?"

The little girl slowly stopped playing with a flower in her hand and looked up at the man.

"Oh, how delightful! Food!"

Part 175:

I sat on the ground and watched, as Cassiel and Samantha fought a group of monsters in the clearing ahead.

We've been traveling together for a couple months now, and we're now on a planet run by one of the dukes. It's a hellish world, made of dirt and rock, with a thick atmosphere and barely enough normal oxygenated air to breathe. Luckily, I had solved this by yelling "Oxygen!" at the top of my lungs to make the air safe enough to breathe. A bit of "Filter" and some other words, and just like that, I've practically terraformed an entire planet.

The surface itself though, it is a grim world. I've yet to see any life aside from skeletons that have been reanimated, zombies, orcs, goblins, and even a troll or two. The only life on this world is demon or monster life.

Samantha appears to be having the time of her life. She's incredibly strong, mentally and spiritually, but especially physically. I fashioned her a new weapon after she broke her whip within a week of using it. I think the new weapon fits her personality better.

It's a 14 foot long steel pipe.

She gleefully smashes enemies around, left and right, any who come within the dreaded 'kill zone' as I've started calling it... they die immediately. She almost seems to be treating the whacking off of heads from her enemies as a game of baseball. *Let's see how far I can send their skulls flying!* That's what her body language says.

As for Cassiel, well, let's just say I've discovered that she holds more power than I gave her credit for. At the end of every day, before we all go to bed together, I give Cassiel all my remaining spirit energy. As a result, she is now holding colossal amounts inside of her body.

She releases minuscule amounts of it at a time when she attacks. Her wings have turned out to be a huge advantage, acting as extra limbs that can pull her forwards or push her back to make attacks hit or miss as she desires. On top of that, when she wants, she can shoot beams of pure light out of her hands, which are very effective at slaying the undead monsters we've been facing so many of recently.

As a joke, I started teaching her how to condense light into a ball in her hands, hold her hands at her side, charge it up, and then fire it. It looks exactly like what you'd expect it to, but it's also incredibly powerful, even against non-undead monsters.

Between the two of them, Cassiel for ranged attacking and healing, while Samantha gets up close and personal, I don't actually participate in battles much. It's good training, especially for Cassiel, who seems to be secretly delighting in the deaths of her previous tormentors. Cassiel is one strange angel, you wouldn't think them to be the sort of beings who enjoy killing.

But that's the thing, isn't it? I've found myself thinking a lot more lately, and having a lot more time to do so, since the girls seem to be such a good team together. Something just isn't right. The fact that Cassiel was implied to not be a 'real' angel, and that she's a reborn human... I thought humans became angels when they died? That's what I was taught in church, when I was a child. Maybe there's more to it. I was also told that bad people will be sent to the pits of Hell, and that may be true... it's just that something always seems wrong, no matter how I approach it.

The other option is that only true believers become angels when they die. Maybe people that follow a certain faith? Perhaps those who attend church the most, or maybe those weirdos that go door to door? Heck, what if it's nothing like that, and it's totally random? Maybe they're chosen based on some latent attributes, like intelligence, or strength, or...

I glanced over at Cassiel....Chest size? That would be stupid. Why would god or some gods choose someone for a reason like that? Then again, I remember reading bible stories of angels that came to Earth to lay with the women of the land... and Cassiel clearly has a sex drive... maybe it's not that farfetched.

Meh, I won't get anywhere thinking about it, or by asking her about it. She seems tight lipped about the subject and never mentions the other angels, or her life before becoming one. One time I pushed too hard and she almost broke down into tears. I don't know what her life was like before she died, but it seems to have been pretty horrible. I'm beginning to wonder if... if perhaps she... committed suicide...

Those are dark thoughts though. I'm also having questions about other things. Namely Samantha. Cassiel seemed so traumatized about everything, and yet with just a little bit of time chatting with Samantha, she seemed to be over it, even moving on to... fun stuff. I just don't see how that happened. I can only conclude it was Samantha's doing, but to what end? Samantha, assuming she had some magical power like that, could have convinced Cassiel to stay away from me, and then Samantha would have had me all to herself.

Unless she didn't want it like that. There's also the curiosity I've felt about her motives... Samantha seems sweet and nice, but she seems to love killing things, far more so than Cassiel or I. Is that her demon side? As a succubus, I think I know a bit about them from the classes I used to take before I got in the cryopod. Succubus exist and thrive off the, erm, *energy* of men. There

also exists the male form, which are called an Incubus. I have yet to meet one of those, but I'm beginning to wonder if anything I learned as a youth about gods, angels, demon names, all of those things... were all of them real? Was every world religion correct at the same time? Is there really no main overarching God?

There has to be. Nobody has mentioned him yet, but the other option would be the theory of evolution. I don't mean demonic evolution either (Which much more closely resembles *mutation*, I might add), I mean the slow and gradual alteration of a species into separate and distinct subspecies over a long period of time. If no creator exists, perhaps gods or angels were the first life to evolve, and they had billions of years to reach a high level of intelligence before other life evolved.

But that makes no sense. Why wouldn't they just destroy the new life? Boredom? They do get bored, and from what I've heard, gods, angels, and demons feel many emotions I would describe as "human-like".

I just can't bring myself to believe that all the fantastical elements of the universe evolved from nothing. There has to be a main God, a Creator, if you will. If I can just-

"...-ero? Are you even listening to me?" I jerked back as Samantha's face was smack dab in front of mine. Good heavens, she scared the life out of me!

"Huh? What?!" I jerked up to my feet, looking all around, as Cassiel and Samantha both stared at me.

"He's daydreaming again. Must be nice, just let the girls do all the fighting, and enjoy the *view*." Samantha rolled her eyes as she wagged her tail slightly.

"I'm sure whatever he was thinking about, it was important!" Cassiel, as usual, came immediately to my rescue. "Hero, we defeated all the demons and monsters! Aren't you happy?"

I nodded at Cassiel and smiled at Samantha. "Good job. Sorry, I was just... *strategizing* about what to do next."

Samantha feigned disbelief as she licked her lips slowly. "Mmm, I see. Well if it's like that, then I guess it doesn't matter much. It's getting late, so do the thing again."

I quickly pat Cassiel and Samantha on the heads as both of them smiled. "Great job today, girls!" Then I sighed as I aimed my hand at a flat spot nearby. " *House. Bed. Chair. Chair. Chair. Table. Lantern. Blanket. Blanket.* "

Instantly, a cute and quaint little house appeared a few yards away. This has become the new standard for our living. It's like a mobile home, except I can just make it vanish out of existence when I'm done.

The three of us entered, as I erected several layers of barriers and traps, just in case someone ambushed us during the night.

We put on a pot of tea, chatted for a while, and then we all went to bed together, as we've done for the last few months.

Life is pretty great right now.

Part 176:

I awoke in the morning as I usually did, with Samantha sleeping face down on top of me and Cassiel hugging my right side. I've grown used to it, but it's never any less pleasant. I don't know why it became a thing, but they both seem to like it and I can't say I don't. Another restless night, but I had still recovered my spiritual energy so in the end, it didn't matter much.

As usual, I slip out, carefully moving Samantha around without waking her up, and crawling out myself. I no longer bother casting 'sleep' on them though, since they both sleep like rocks. Maybe it's because they know that if something shows up, I'll just beat it to death, so they don't have to worry about it. Pff, must be nice having so few cares in the world.

I sit down at the table and think about the plan for today. I don't know whose residence this world is, only that a 'duke' lives here. Samantha seems to know who a lot of the high ranked demons are, but she always seems hesitant to appear with me in front of them. It must be bad blood or something. Hell, maybe she's on their version of a 'most wanted' list so she can't afford to be seen without leaving the demons alive. At least, that's the feeling I get from it.

We stumbled into this world by finding a door in the labyrinth that I sensed a lot of energy coming from, so there's definitely something powerful here. I assumed it was a duke, but it might not be. The energy seems to be omnipresent, it's all around me and I don't know where it's actually coming from. But as I travel in one direction, I do feel the buzzing increasing. What's *more* interesting though is that I am the only one who feels it.

After eating some food, I go outside and experiment as I usually do. Today, I have a new power I want to try out.

" Telekinesis! "

Alriiiiight, time to see if it worked. I aim my hand over at a nearby rock and try to move it with my mind. Nothing seems to happen. *Use the force, Hero.* I give myself a mental pep talk and try again. This time, I feel the rock start to shake a little bit. My excitement is so palpable!

I hold my hand up and try pulling the rock to me. It shakes, and starts crawling along the ground, very slowly. I concentrate, more and more and more.... come on, come on... suddenly, the rock BLASTS off the ground, flying at my hand, but it misses by an inch and smashes me in the face!

Luckily it doesn't hurt, but I do feel a bit foolish. What's interesting is this appears to be another active-use spell. I can leave it active all I want, but if I use it, I feel my spiritual energy

drain ever so slightly. It's like a weaker version of push/pull, but it isn't a wave of energy that hits everything around me, so that is good.

A while later, as I'm playing around, I hear a voice at the doorway behind me. I had already detected her waking up, but I pretend to have not done so. "Morning, Hero. What are you doing?" Cassiel yawns sleepily. Samantha isn't awake yet.

I indicate the rock in my hands, I explain to her. "I tried using a new ability called 'telekinesis, it lets me move objects around with my mind." I feel a grin creep along my face, as I whip my hand back around towards her. "Like this!" I quickly pull her towards me.

She yelps but I catch her with my arm and she giggles. "You startled me! But wow, that seems like a useful ability!"

I smile and lean in, kissing her deeply. The passionate embrace lasts a second or two as we linger together.

"We don't spend much time alone together, do we?" She and I both sit down on the ground together as she leans her head over on my shoulder. I pause. "It's like Samantha's always there too, you know."

"Yes, but that's okay. Samantha is a kind loving girl. I see why you love her. And you love me too, because you have enough love flowing from you to spare for both of us equally." Cassiel closed her eyes as she yawned again.

I love Samantha, huh? Do I? Do I love Cassiel too? What is love, anyway? I spend time with them, I talk with them, I enjoy being with both of them. I suppose that's love. If we will be together forever or for a very long time, I'd like that. I suppose that could be love too. But I've never felt passionate about anything in my life. The only thing I truly want is to make sure no friend of mine ever dies again... like... Phoebe did. I feel my thoughts returning as I grow quiet again and dwell on the past.

Phoebe. She died because of me. While I immediately went out and had a good time the night she died, and I seem to be ignoring her death even now... I'm not. I can't bring her back, but maybe I can prevent Cassiel and Samantha from dying. I don't want that. I could never want that.

Cassiel and I sit and chat for a while before I feel Samantha wake up and come outside to join us. "I see you two are having a good time. Mind if I join in?"

After they eat some breakfast that I magic into existence, I tear down the shelter and we head out.

* * *

The buzzing noise is getting noticeably louder in my head. It's actually getting quite distracting.

As we walk along, with me following the direction the feeling comes from, I can feel myself rubbing my temples over and over. I am, at this point, permanently wincing. I've tried silencing the noise with various spells, including *Silence*, *Deafen*, *Mute*, *Quiet*, *Halt*, *Stop*, and many more, but nothing seems to work.

There's a big crater in the distance. It's almost like a massive meteor fell into it. Could this be what wiped out all life on this planet? Something like the meteor that killed the dinosaurs on Earth? The crater is fairly large, but not "Planet destruction" sized. It's maybe a half mile across the diameter, and it's very circular.

Once I spot the crater, I decide to increase the speed. "Hold on a second, girls." I wrap my arms around both of them, and jam my foot into the ground, propelling myself forwards with insane speed. Thanks to the powers I've received as God King, I could move this fast all day long and never tire, but the girls, as strong as they are, simply cannot keep up with my body's raw power. Samantha is actually very strong and seems to have a large energy supply, but she rarely uses it. Cassiel is comparatively weak but her energy dwarfs mine, mostly because she seems to have no limit to the amount she can store and I give her my monstrous leftover energy every night.

The crater was almost 5 miles in the distance, but I dash over there in about ten seconds. The speed is unbelievable. When we're just before the lip of the crater, I set the girls down. Samantha isn't too bad, but Cassiel seems fairly nauseous. I'd try to talk to them, but that goddamn ringing noise in my ear is unbearable at this point. I need to turn it off!

Samantha and I walk over to the crater and as we peer in, we both gasp.

Down inside the crater is something I did not expect to see at all.

It's a spaceship.

Part 177: Ship

The ringing is so insufferable at this point. It was like when I stepped towards the crater and my head passed the lip of it and I could see the spaceship, the ringing tripled in power. In fact, it hit me so hard in my brain that I lost my balance, tumbling forwards end over end for a few seconds until I smashed into the side of the spaceship at the bottom. The instant I impacted it, the ringing stopped completely.

My head suddenly cleared up, I shook it off and stood up. A fall like this wouldn't hurt me in the slightest. Samantha slowly made her way down the slope, and Cassiel, having picked herself up and shaken the nausea off, flew the short distance into the crater in the blink of an eye. *Those wings are useful, I should get a pair for myself in the future.*

"Hero! Are you all right?" Cassiel lands and runs up to me, looking me over quickly with her eyes.

"Yeah, a little fall like that couldn't possibly hurt this body made of iron. You know that!" I stick my tongue out at her. "But that being said, thank you for the concern. You two stay here, I'll check and see what's inside."

Samantha finally made her way down to the bottom of the slope. I thought for a second I saw panic on her face as she eyed the ship, but it vanished quickly. "Hero, you should be careful. There could be anything inside that ship... anything at all..."

I nod. "Like I told Cassiel, you stay here. I'll see what's inside."

Something is making me very nervous. I cannot sense what is inside this ship. There is a hollow, black void in my all-seeing sphere. Whatever's in this ship, seeing it may be a bad idea. The ship itself is probably a football field in size, counting the crowd sitting sections and whatnot. It's incredibly large, with a massive set of engines in the back, a thick tail section of the ship, which tapers down and narrows itself as it gets to the front, where I presume the pilot section is, and strangely it has no wings, it's shaped like a bullet. Thick at the rear, slim at the front.

As I make my way around it, looking for a door or something, I spot something that makes me gasp aloud. Directly in the middle broadside of the ship, there is a faded, but still visible insignia. And it's written in English characters.

G.E.F.

And just below that in smaller letters, a few of them are faded out but I can guess at their contents.

G-lax- -xpl-rati-n F--ce

Galaxy Exploration Force? Is this like a ship from Earth? More importantly, why are the letters in plain English?

As I walk towards the front, a familiar logo greets me. It's a flag, with stars and stripes. However, this flag seems to have more than two hundred stars. But with the appearance of the flag, it's all but confirmed. *This is a human vessel.*

After a while of walking around, one thing I notice for sure; this ship is not going anywhere. It's a mess. I can't find a door anywhere, but when I get to the front, I find what is definitely the pilot section. There's a large bubble window that's shattered and in pieces everywhere. This planet was originally very toxic, so assuming that this ship crash landed, if the atmosphere of this place entered it, that would have likely killed all the crew assuming they were unable to airlock the rest of the ship.

I step in and gasp again. This... this is unreal.

All around me are familiar looking things. I feel like I've seen this before, maybe on an episode of some old sci-fi TV shows. Bodies litter the floor, as I take note of old desiccated skeletons, bits and pieces of their original garments still being worn.

The interior is absolutely ruined. Their crash landing must have instantly killed everyone on the bridge, if the planet's toxic air didn't. The walls, covered with some material that I assume is a far advanced version of flat-screen technology, are cracked and chipped, likely non-functional.

I make my way towards what is apparently a doorway. As I walk up to it, I... *hear something.* On the other side of the door.

I carefully touch the door, and I hear a hissing sound as the door opens. Apparently the ship is still powered? How long has it been here though...

As the door opens, I almost jump back in fright. There's a human standing there, staring directly at me! Jesus Christ! The man raises his hand and waves. "Greeting: Hello, I am glad to serve you! Hello, I am glad to serve you! Hello, I am glad to serve you!"

Wait, hold on a second. That's not a human, it's... an android? It looks so humanlike that I thought it was a real man. But... he just stands there, waving his hand at me, as if he had just been reactivated and had a recurring bug in his system.

I walk behind him and he turns to face me, as he keeps waving. "Hello, I am glad to serve you! Hello, I am glad to serve you!"

This is getting kind of creepy. I decide to try speaking to 'him'. "Can you understand my words?"

The robot halts his greeting. "Response: Yes! I am fully aware of the words you speak!"

Oh? He's not bugged? Well, that's a good thing, I guess. "What is this ship, exactly? What happened to it?"

The android paused as he considered my words. Then he spoke. "Reply: This ship is humanity's one hundred and fortieth galactic exploration device! The crew of one hundred and twenty was sent on a mission to explore distant worlds, in an effort to bolster the war effort. As for the fate of the ship, only I managed to survive thanks to my very durable body. All one hundred and twenty crew members died as a result of the crash or toxic inhalation due to the planet's atmospheric composition."

This was a lot of information to take in. "Wait, you said to bolster the war effort. The war effort against... who?"

The android tilted his head to the side, in a mock expression of curiosity. "Response: Why, the Volgrim, of course. How do you not know about them?"

Part 178:

Scientists have estimated that in the Milky Way alone, there are over one hundred billion stars. If we count the 'local group' of nearby galaxies that are not expanding away from each other, that number explodes to 700 billion.

But as for the number of *galaxies* in the entire *universe*? We can only speculate. Each galaxy could contain hundreds of billions of stars, and the best estimate for the number of actual galaxies, in the observable universe at the least, is another hundred billion.

That means there are likely over a *billion trillion* stars in the universe. Humanity started on one tiny little dot.

And we thought we were *alone*? Of course we weren't. How naive.

The android looked at me. "Confusion: I am having difficulty processing the idea of a human that does not know of the existence of the Volgrim. Explanation: They are the scourge of the Milky Way galaxy. Humanity battled them for over a hundred years before this ship was sent on a mission to find an expansionary space to colonize."

I pause. "When did we start fighting the Volgrim? When did they first appear?"

The android pauses. "Error. That information is classified as Top Secret."

"Uh, okay, so how long have you been crash landed on this planet?" I guess if I can't get one question answered, I will try another.

The android's eyes appear to stare past me for a second as he pulls up the answer. "Response: According to my sensors, I have been crashed on this planet, awaiting a response to my distress signal for one-hundred-million, two-hundred-thousand, five hundred-forty-five years, nine months, seventeen days, and-"

I cut him off. "Alright, damn, I get the picture. It's been a long time then." *My god, the cryopod really did hold me for a hundred million years? What the hell is going on then?*

I turn back to the android. "It feels odd calling you 'android'. What is your designation?"

"Response: My designation is OMEN. I am the Original Mechanical Exploratory Neohuman. It is a pleasure to make your acquaintance." OMEN bows stiffly, and then pulls himself up. Strange, for an android, he seems to move and speak stiffly. Maybe robotics didn't advance very far in the future? Or maybe...

"OMEN, when did your ship initially launch to explore space? What was the date you started traveling from Earth towards this star system?"

OMEN paused as he calculated the answer. "Query: Why are you using an incorrect starting location? I was originally created and built and launched from the Mars Planetary Base, as most of Earth was in ruins due to the Volgrim's initial attack. Ignoring initial question: I was launched on the G.E.F. 140 at..."

OMEN stopped speaking for a second. "Error: Exact date is missing, due to corruption of memory data or due to tampering. However, the rough date was the 24th century, Gregorian Calendar time. Hypothesis: Due to the amount of time taken to respond to my distress signal, I can only assume you are the last human alive in the galaxy. Is my hypothesis correct?"

I shake my head. "No, there are millions of humans left alive. However, this is the first I've seen of anything resembling space-faring technology. All the other humans appear to be stuck in weird tiny planetoids or other such planets where they live in a perpetual medieval or bronze age."

OMEN paused again. "Query: Have the demons and Volgrim been eradicated from the universe as we know it?"

I shake my head. "No. In fact, I arrived at this planet thanks to a strange labyrinth with a door that opened up here as a portal on this world. The labyrinth is filled with demons and monsters."

OMEN nodded as he processed the information. "Dismay: I see. That would mean the demon-Volgrim alliance won out and humanity was crushed. This is very unfortunate. Query: How were you able to locate this ship without a transponder?"

I shrugged. "I felt a buzzing in the back of my head, it got louder when I walked this way."

OMEN halted all speech and movement and stared at me blankly for almost fifteen seconds. I was starting to get very nervous. Finally, he spoke up again. "Query: Are you... one of the candidates?"

Part 179:

"Candidates? What candidates? What are those?" I felt curiosity nibbling at the back of my brain.

"Response: That information is classified as Top Secret. If you do not know what the candidates are, you must not be a candidate." Great, this robot has a sense of humor. A joke if ever there was one. I'm pretty sure he just committed a logical fallacy too, but- wait. Hold on a second.

"OMEN, what would it take for you to declassify those documents so that I could read them or listen to them?" It was worth a shot.

"Hypothesis: If you were the sole remaining member of mankind, or could demonstrably prove that you were the highest ranked remaining member of the Earth Military, as set in the charter made before this crew set off to this planet, then I would be able to declassify those documents for you." OMEN nodded in the affirmative as he stared ahead blankly at me.

Damn. I stiffed myself by telling him that I wasn't the last remaining human. Better to try one last thing. I raised my hand at him. "*Unclassify*." A wave of magic left my body.

Instantly, the ship came alive. Multiple doors slammed shut in the distance, as did the door behind me. Alarms went off all around, as the ship blared to life, and red lights activated where before the ship had only been illuminated by sunlight from the distant star.

"ALERT. ALERT. SPIRITUAL ENERGY OUTPUT DETECTED. SHIFTING TO RED ALERT MODE. DEMON THREAT CLASS A+ IS PREDICTED BASED ON ENERGY LEVELS OF SCANNED LIFEFORM. CREW IS DOWN. REVERT TO AUTONOMOUS DEFENSE MODE. ALERT. ALERT." Jesus Christ! Holy shit!

"Wait no! I didn't mean it!" I held my hands up with the universal sign for *I give up* but the android in front of me ignored it. His pupils were red now as he shifted into autonomous mode or whatever. Not good.

And from the back of the ship, I heard an incredibly loud noise of doors flying open and... *something* approaching. Then it appeared as the last door opened.

A massive goddamn robot that took up the entire hallway, armed to the teeth. My escape route was cut off too! Not good.

That's fine, I'll just have to take control of the situation. I felt my mind thinking, as I rushed forwards. The robot blasted a barrage of laser fire at me, knocking me back off my feet. My body

was tough, but I had reinforced myself many times over the last few weeks with layers of barriers to protect myself from projectiles.

Terrifyingly, these laser blasts shot right through my barriers, smashing into my skin and burning like I had acid dumped on myself.

All right, if it's come to this! " **PUSH!!** " A blast of energy surged out of my body, as the tightly enclosed space exploded all around me, sending OMEN flying towards the massive battle robot, smashing into it and falling into a crumpled mess on the ground.

"ALERT. ALERT. SUBJECT RECLASSIFIED. THREAT LEVEL S. INITIATE PURGING PROTOCOLS. MICRO-DREADNAUGHTS DEPLOY IMMEDIATELY. ALERT. ALERT."

Before I could even think to myself *what the hell is a micro-dreadnaught?*, a horrifying nauseating feeling surged over my body, as I stumbled and fell forwards. The armored goliath in front of me was hitting me with some kind of magic purging beam, I felt my Spiritual Energy draining at alarming speeds, and it was making it impossible for me to move, or really, do anything.

Just then, the side of the ship ripped off, as Samantha and Cassiel came to my rescue. Samantha had torn the metallic side off with her bare hands (holy crap she's strong!) and Cassiel was charging her spiritual light attack as I'd taught her. The instant a gap opened up and Cassiel spotted the robot attacking me, she fired. A spectacular blast of light SMASHED into the gigantic robot, blasting it into fifty bazillion pieces, as the energy beam on me cut off.

I stood up, gasping. "God-damn! Thanks, you two saved my life!"

Cassiel nodded curtly, no smile visible on her face. "I'm just returning the favor. But we have bigger issues!"

From the back of the ship, I heard many, many loud sounds coming. *I don't want to know what those sounds are from.*

I couldn't sense the inside of the ship or what was coming at all. But what I did know is that no matter how strong Cassiel, Samantha, or I was, we could not take on as many of those things that were coming as I could actually hear coming.

"Let's get the hell out of here!" I jumped forwards, grabbing the girls, burying my foot into the ground, as I slammed down with all my strength, jumping two miles in a single, swift movement. At the high part of the arc, I let Cassiel go so she could fly, and whipped Samantha around to hold her with both arms. This was not going to be a soft impact.

Just before we hit the ground, I had an idea form in my head, thanks to the Crown of Solomon. I aimed my mind at the ground, and quickly yelled. "Cushion!"

When I hit the ground, it felt like... landing in a pool of jello that quickly reformed itself and hardened. I whipped my head back as I set Samantha down. Behind us, way back at the crater, ten massive mechanical robots, clearly designed for serious war, were chasing after us.

Cassiel landed beside me. "They'll be here in seconds! What do we do?!"

I quickly searched my mind with the Crown. "I've got this."

I grabbed hold of Cassiel and Samantha's hand. " **TELEPORT!** "

* * *

Seconds later, we reappeared next to the portal, over 50 miles away. After entering it, I quickly turned back around. " *Seal!* " Just like that, the portal closed behind us, forever.

We all slumped to the ground, our nerves jittery. Samantha was the first to speak up. "You idiot. I warned you."

Cassiel had already calmed down. She seemed to have lost the nerves she had when I first met her. "You um... want to tell us what just happened there?"

Part 180:

I stared at Samantha intently, my eyes looking directly into hers. "You know something. Admit it."

She shifted uncomfortably on the ground. "Well, of course I do. I'm just... surprised you don't. You're only *human* after all. You seem to be wholly unaware about the Energy Wars."

Energy Wars? This is the first time I've heard about them. "What are the Energy Wars? We almost died because you kept your mouth shut back there. You need to tell me now."

Samantha sighed as she leaned back against the wall. The only light visible in the dark corridor was Cassiel's soft luminescence caused by her angelic aura. "Listen... we're an item, right? I don't like hearing you order me around. I haven't told you because it hurts to remember what... what happened back then. You know, humans and demons... we're supposed to be mortal enemies. The fact the two of us are even together... it's a big leap, you know."

Cassiel nodded. "I was there for the tail end of the Energy Wars. It was brutal. Those were the days when..." Cassiel cut herself off, before continuing on. "A lot of people died. Easily billions. Sometimes I wonder how I was able to be among the last members of the Resurrection Project. There were too many others who were worthier than me."

I felt myself quietly looking back and forth between them. What happened? How did humanity die? There was also what the android had told me. He said that by the 24th century, only a few hundred years after I was put in the cryopod, Earth was basically destroyed. It happened that quickly? Who were these Volgrim? How did they destroy the original birthplace of humanity so efficiently and so quickly?

I sighed. "Listen... if you don't want to tell me... that's fine. But... we could have been killed back there. If you care about Cassiel and I, you should tell us what you know."

Samantha looked around, clearly feeling uncomfortable about all of this. "All right... I'll tell you. But this carries a heavy penalty. If any other demons ever found out I said anything, I will be summarily executed. The Energy Wars are extremely secret, especially the finer details of how they worked. Most demons and humans had their minds wiped after those wars concluded."

Samantha paused before glancing at Cassiel. "I wonder why they didn't wipe your memories? I mean, you were a captive, right?"

Cassiel blushed as she looked down. "I don't know. After the war was over, I was there for a very, very long time. To say I lost track of the passing of time, that would be an understatement. I never thought I would see the light of day. They kept giving me tiny doses of thought energy, just to keep me alive. I just don't know *why* though."

Samantha got up and walked over to me, plopping down beside me and resting her head on my shoulder. "Well, in any case. I might as well explain. But you can't start with the Volgrim. You have to start at the beginning. The very beginning."

I stared down the empty corridor. "Well, it's not like we lack time. We're just three immortal beings, you know. Might as well hear the whole story."

Cassiel gracefully sat down next to me as we all leaned against the wall. Samantha spoke next. "It all started long before humans were ever a threat to demons, far back after the first great battle that started off the Great War between Angels and Demons."

Part 181:

Zeus eyed the drawing in front of him. "So these are the most likely successors of Hercules' power, hm? They don't look particularly strong." He traced his finger around each one lazily. "This seems pointless. There are plenty of blond haired young men out there. Any one of them could inherit the power."

Raphael nodded sagely as he carefully watched his king. "The ceremony guarantees that his power will transfer to another. However, the only criteria specified was that it had to be someone who resembled him, and who possessed a nature similar to his own."

Zeus cursed under his breath. "If only my son had heeded my counsel and had a successor. Just one child..."

Raphael waved it off. "It would not matter, my liege. His power does not automatically inherit to his own children, or their own children. Only someone with a similar nature."

The king of the gods set the drawing down below him onto the tiny table before leaning back into his large wooden chair. "What does that even mean, Raphael? What is his 'nature' exactly? Is it his looks? His personality? His birth as a demigod? His goal in life? It sounds like gibberish to me. Totally unreliable."

Raphael nodded. "Yes, but by being vague, we guaranteed that his power would *always* pass on. If we had gotten too specific, that would mean that it might not find a suitable host if and when he died, which would mean his abilities would be lost forever."

Gabriel, also sitting at the table, nodded quietly. "Even if we can't find the next in line, they will eventually show themselves. The Hero will always possess very unique traits that make him or her stand out in a crowd. If we keep our eyes sharp for one who is rising above the rest of the rabble, then we will easily find the next Hero."

Zeus perked up. "Hm? Did I hear you say 'him or her'? So even the gender is in question here? Do we have anything solid to look for?"

"To be honest, my liege, nothing. But more importantly, let's stop worrying about his successor for now. If the successor is found and killed, the power will simply transfer to another anyway. But in the meantime, the demons seem to have grown restless. They have reappeared, attacking villages and towns fleetingly, only to be driven back by the humans."

Gabriel pointed to the orb sitting on the table in front of him. "This is a globe of Earth. I constructed it myself by exiting the planet's space and entering the black void. I used magic to

copy the exact landmass size, and positioning of every piece of soil on the planet. It's 100% accurate."

He indicated the city of Babylon with his finger. "These humans have grown mighty over the last few decades. They have a new leader who just assumed power, and he seems to revere the gods greatly. Nebuchadnezzar the Second, they call him." Gabriel, currently in his shrunken form, raised his head to grin at Raphael. "He's named, along with his father, after the Babylonian god Nebu, the god of wisdom. He worships you but doesn't even know it."

Raphael nodded quietly. "Naturally. We're all worshiped by one name or another among the various religions out there. If I'm not called Nebu, or Raphael, I'm called Athena or Metis, or some other name. Get on with it."

"Hahhh... fine, always raining on my day." Gabriel looked back at the globe. "Anyway, based on its cultural influence, I'm hoping that whoever is the first candidate will be located somewhere in Babylon. I have estimated that the candidate will usually be born in a major city controlled by a major world power, this way their abilities are not wasted as a simple slave or a farmer. They need influence and political power to shape the face of humanity, as it were."

Raphael spoke up. "Gabriel, I think you are guessing too much. It's been a few decades already, and yet no major candidates have appeared yet. If it were a major world power where he appeared, that would make little sense. I suspect he may instead appear in a minor village, somewhere under strife, where his abilities would allow him to crush evil, and especially demons. A hero is called where the need is greatest."

Zeus sat back in his chair and stared up at the ceiling. "Hero, hmm? I suppose knowing Hercules, his successor would usually end up being one who excelled on the field of battle, right? I can't see his heroic abilities being endowed upon a human of intellectual abilities. I loved my son, but he was a lunkhead. We should examine the lower classes too. Perhaps we should create some new tenets of religion among the humans to draw out the ones who are excelling among them, perhaps as offerings to the gods. Something like that."

Raphael nodded. "A wise recommendation. I will have one of the lower angels start working on it immediately."

Gabriel returned the nod. "Yes, that would be the fastest, and most efficient way to discover him. Again though, we need to worry about the demons. The humans have begun using iron armor and weapons instead of copper or bronze. They are steadily beating them back, but I fear this may be a ruse. I believe the demons are pretending to be weak."

Raphael stroked his beard slowly. "Say, would it not be interesting to find out that Satan were still alive?"

Gabriel raised an eyebrow. "You saw it with your own eyes. I smote him with a single blast. No demon can resist the Sunlight from Heaven."

Raphael sighed. "Yes, I suppose not. But, he is a demon... and demons are so.... tricky."

Zeus waved it off as he lowered his head back to the table. "Either way, if he's alive or dead, we may have few troops left, but those that are, are among the strongest of our kind. We will not be defeated so easily, our power is concentrated for a reason. And since he has no way to reach the Gate to Heaven, now that it is located in an unseen corner of Mount Olympus, he will never come here again. Even if he found it, he knows not what the password is to open the gate."

The two archangels shrugged their shoulders at the same time. "If he comes, we will fight. We will do what we must." Gabriel stood up. "Now that we've concluded the official business, I'll be off. My lord." Gabriel bowed. Soon afterwards, Raphael made his exit as well, leaving Zeus to his own thoughts.

Part 182: The Great

Amelia grinned as she danced along the highway. She was humming some tune to herself that had bubbled up from the memories of one of the snacks she ate a little earlier that day.

"Carthage had so many yummy people! I can't wait to go to Babylon and see how much they've grown!" She skipped along, merrily enjoying her day.

A voice inside of her spoke. *You seem to be having a lot more fun than usual, princess. Is there something particularly good about today?*

"Oh Levi, if only you knew! This is the day I finally take my revenge! I'm SOOOO excited!" She giggled as she thought of how great it was going to be to devour the descendants of those who killed mommy and papa. She would have eaten the actual people who did the deed, but she had gotten distracted for a few hundred years and rampaged all over the world.

But now, it was time. Time for snacks!

She could feel her stomach growling again. *I apologize, princess. The hunger will never stop, whether I'm inside of you or not.*

She giggled again. "That's okay~ I don't get full anyway, so eating all day long doesn't make my tummy hurt!"

* * *

She meandered about aimlessly for several hours, until she could spot in the distance the great walls of the city she would soon conquer. However, up ahead of her, there appeared to be a large army making preparations to move out. "Hmm? Who are all those men?"

Leviathan sighed from within her. *My princess, I know you don't pay too much attention to the politics of the people you devour, but based on the banner those men are flying, they appear to be soldiers of the Greek empire.*

"Hmm? Greek? But this is Babylon. Are they about to attack the city? Did I accidentally stumble in a battleground? Ooooh! Battles mean lots of dead things to eat!"

Leviathan sighed again. *Always with the one-track mind, I see.*

Amelia stared ahead into the distance, concentrating her vision as she somehow zoomed in with a thousand times the focal viewing distance of a normal human's eyes. "Hm? There appears to be a Greek flag hanging over the walls of Babylon. Have they... have they already been attacked?!"

She stomped her foot on the ground. "No no no no!! This is not fair! I wanted to eat the Babylon people while they were still screaming and begging me to stop! Some meanie took my food from me!"

As she walked along glumly towards the city, she moaned in annoyance. "Dang it, now I have to eat some filthy Greeks instead. Life just isn't fair!"

Leviathan concurred. *Yes, life is not fair, but I feel you could find something worse to complain about.*

As she walked along, she heard the sound of a horn blaring in the distance, as five horseman rode up to her on the road. "Hm? It appears that I'm getting delivery service today! I'm so lucky!"

The men rode up and stopped a hundred or so feet away from her. The man leading them appeared to be an important person. His figure was somewhat imposing, though not so much to Amelia. She wasn't intimidated by very much.

"Who are you boys? Are you here to pick on a lonely little girl, traveling all by herself?" She pretended to cower in fright. "I hope you're not here to t-take my chastity!"

The man leading them stepped down, drawing his sword as he approached. He was a tall man, an imposing 6'3", dwarfing the size of his men. He had lion colored hair, yellow in nature, and more interestingly, he had one black colored eye, and one blue colored eye.

"Hold. I know of your evil deeds, foul monster." The man glared at her as he stopped some feet away. "Your tales of murder and destruction precede you. I am surprised to see you speaking normally though, as the rumors had said that you were a mute witch who only cackled as she devoured her victims whole."

Amelia frowned. "Hmm? That can't be me!" She tapped her lips thoughtfully. "I'm just a little girl, on my way to visit my papa in Babylon!"

The man grimaced. One of his men yelled at him. "Alexander! Don't turn your back to her! She can move as fast as the wind!"

Leviathan perked up from inside Amelia, as he listened intently. *Oho? Alexander? A tall imposing man of Greek descent who leads an army? This human is actually quite famous!*

Amelia giggled. "Oh dear, a human! How will I ever cope!" She moved, in an instant, as her jaw stretched itself, unhinging in preparation to gobble the man up whole.

Before she could do so, however, the man deftly stepped to the side, dodging her inhumanly fast attack, as he delivered a kick to her chest. "By the power of the gods, I will release you from this world!" Lunging forwards, moving at an unexpected speed, he stabbed Amelia in the heart.

She screamed in pain. "Ahh! It burns! Ahhhh!!!!!"

Jerking herself back, she leaped out of his way. "You! You're not a normal human! No human moves that fast!"

Alexander nodded grimly. "And you're no ordinary little girl. It seems we both have secrets, but unlike you, I will announce myself. I am Alexander the 3rd, leader of the Greeks, and a descendant of the original Hero! By my power, I will release you from this world!"

He started moving his hands around, as he chanted a powerful spell. "*Gladium de lumine!*" His sword glowed white hot, as he charged forwards, swinging it dozens of times at once. Amelia was caught wholly off guard by the power of this singular human, as he cut off her right leg, and her right arm, sending her screaming and crying to the ground.

"Uwaahhh! It hurts! It hurts!!" Tears poured from her eyes, as she felt waves of pain cascading through her body. She fought the urge to vomit desperately. She had never felt pain like this before, as she had not faced even a single threat in the last few hundred years that was on par with her.

Alexander grimaced. "*Good.* It had better hurt, because no amount of pain I inflict on you will ever compare to the atrocities you've committed, foul demon!"

Amelia bit her lip as Leviathan spoke inside of her in an alarmed voice. "*Princess! Unleash me, and I will destroy this man in an instant!*"

"No..." She whispered, as she fought the pain erupting from her severed limbs. "No... I... I will... make him... **PAY!**"

With her one free hand, she quickly began chanting a powerful spell, releasing it at an impossibly fast speed. New limbs blasted out of her severed ones insanely fast. In the span of three seconds, she had regrown her limbs anew. She rose to her feet as a crazy, insane smile took over.

"Heh... heh heh heh... this has made me... very very mad... hurting a little girl... I'm not the monster here.... **YOU ARE!**"

She leaped at Alexander, her mouth unhinging as a terrifying demonic roar blasted out of her mouth. The pitch was incredibly high, yet just low enough for humans to perceive, but the very air around them all shook, almost as if the air itself were enraged. Far off, in the city of Babylon, dogs, cats, and other animals started rampaging due to the awful sound that only they could seem to perceive.

Alexander stumbled back, as her hands started stabbing forwards, making small sonic booms each time she jabbed them forwards.

However, Alexander was no slouch. He had personally trained for a year under the Gods of Olympus, learning the art of war, and preparing himself to become a Hero who would liberate his people. A little girl could not and would not be the death of him on this day.

Her unhinged mouth was a terrifying spectacle indeed, but Alexander kept a calm head, taunting her as she attacked. "I thought maybe with all those theatrics, you might be a challenge, but you're still just a spoiled little BRAT!" Taking the flat of his sword, the Gordian Knot, he pounded her across the face, sending her flying to the side, end over end, until she landed in a crumpled mess at the edge of a great ravine.

Alexander's eyes glowed, as he activated his heroic ability. *Prediction.*

His blue eye possessed the ability to see a short time into the future, allowing him to predict the attacks of another in battle, making him an unstoppable force on the battlefield. His left eye allowed him to move things slightly with his mind, a limited form of Telekinesis. Together, they allowed him to predict an opponent's attacks, and manipulate their attacks in subtle ways, causing his opponents to miss him in battle.

With these two abilities activated on his eighteenth birthday, he had become an impossibly strong fighter. Amelia could never hope to defeat him once he turned his ability on.

But Amelia didn't know this.

* * *

Hours later, Amelia was battered, bruised, and broken. The man of front of her was perfectly calm, as he stared down at the innocent looking, yet absolutely terrifying child in front of him. "Finally, your evil will come to an end." He raised his sword up to cut off her head.

Amelia glanced towards the ravine, only twenty feet away. Her body was badly damaged, but her right leg appeared to be fine. Digging that foot in the ground, she leaped out of the way, avoiding Alexander's attack entirely. As she fell off the edge she found herself thinking one thought. *Hero. A terrifying existence, a true monster.*

Unfortunately for Alexander, he would pass away at the tender young age of thirty-three, his death suspected due to poisoning by a jealous successor. To this day, no evidence exists of this truth.

Part 183: Immortality

"Is immortality truly desirable?" The wizened old man stared pointedly at his student, who was painting a pretty mural on a flattened piece of wood.

"Well, yes. Why shouldn't it be? Immortality means you would never have to worry about dying. It would give you a long life to learn all, know all, and do all." The much younger man made some broad strokes with the blue paint, coloring in a bit of plain looking sky.

"Are you certain of that? Can you not find any negatives in the pursuit of immortality?" The old man pressed him a bit harder. He always got so dogged when he had some point to make.

The young man sighed. "Well, I can't see very many, to be honest. I suppose maybe boredom, outliving your friends and lovers and family... what others could there possibly be?"

The old man shook his head. "You have much to learn. Life is not simply about the pursuit of new skills and abilities, it is the pursuit of those in a limited amount of time. One does not become a famous Olympian if he has an eternity to train, he does so because he has such a short existence to make himself known." He pulled his fingers in and out of his beard, as he slowly rocked back and forth in his wooden chair.

The young man blinked slowly, as he examined his painting. He grabbed a bit of the green paint. "All right, but the gods and angels are immortal. Are you saying they live meaningless lives?"

The old man waved his hand. "Plato, you know the answer already. Of course the damned gods are miserable. Think of it, they are so miserable they have to interfere with the affairs of our world just so they can derive some pleasure from their pathetic existences. And in the end, the gods can still be killed, so they are not true immortals. No, a true immortal is unkillable, and cannot die by any normal means. To the best of my limited knowledge, no such being exists."

The young man paused his painting for a moment. "You said 'to the best of your knowledge', so you admit you don't know that for a fact?"

The old man sighed. "True knowledge exists in knowing that you know nothing. I am the wisest man alive, for I know one thing, and that is that I know nothing."

Plato rolled his eyes. "My dear Socrates, you always speak in riddles." He went back to painting, this time dabbing just a speck of red on the wooden canvas. "What good is knowledge if you should pass on to the other world? It becomes like dust scattered to the wind. Immortality may not be perfect, but the upsides surely outweigh the downsides."

Socrates shrugged. "Perhaps, you may be right. However, what is wisdom? Knowledge is not wisdom. Knowledge accrued through a million years of reading will not make one truly wise. The only way to become wise is to learn through action."

"True, but you can perform many more actions if you should live forever." Plato let a small smile creep onto his face.

Socrates guffawed. "Yes, but if you live forever, then you would surely become wise if that were the case. I say that wisdom can be attained even at a young age, but only by those inclined towards it. Think of the gods who died due to their lack of wisdom, gods who lived many eternities longer than a mortal man, mind you! Immortality would not truly help one become wise, it would only make an already wise man grow wiser!"

Plato stepped back from his artwork, and then sat back down, finding a spot he didn't quite like. "The thought holds true, I cannot deny it. However, think of the other benefits of immortality! You would be able to experience all the sights that Mother Earth has to offer! You may be able to enjoy the intimacy of women from many countries as well!"

The old man rubbed a small pendant on his neck, which had a beautiful red gem inset into it. "What would the point be? You can already do that with your short life, yet most men do not do so! A beautiful vista is a sweet thing, but you soon grow used to it. In the same way, immortality would start off sweet and pure, but would sour over time. I believe the only reason the gods have not all killed themselves is that they can experience immortality with each other."

Plato smirked. "Ah! So you think that immortality's downsides become less clear if you are sharing it with others! So let me pose you a question, dear teacher; If instead of yourself simply becoming immortal, you were able to make your friends and family become timeless as well, would that change your opinion of it?"

Socrates actually paused for a few moments, fighting with himself to seek the answer. "Nay. I think of the fact that even if the people I cared about were immortal, what of *their* friends and lovers? Without them, my friends and family would surely become miserable, and that would mean I'd need to spread the immortality forever, until the entire human race were immortal."

Plato frowned. "So? I see no issue there. If loneliness and sadness are the biggest negatives of becoming immortal, surely neutralizing them would make immortality much more positive!"

Socrates snorted as he rubbed his temple. "Yes, but you overlook two important things. One; humans would breed like rabbits, and quickly overtake the entire Earth. Two, living with your worst enemies forever, knowing they would never die, it would eat you up in the inside, continuing to make you miserable for all eternity."

The younger man set down his paintbrush as he turned to face his senior. "But then, assuming humans remained the same, would they not continue to kill each other in ever more glorious bloodbaths, keeping the population down? And if that were the case, would that not make it possible to kill your worst enemies? It seems to be still more positive to me than negative."

"My young friend, you are certainly an idealist. Always looking for the best in a situation." Socrates scratched the back of his head as he leaned forwards in his chair, pulling himself out and up to his feet.

"Ha! I should say the opposite to you! Always a realist, trying to see the worst in a situation! And in the end, I should expect that despite your claims to the contrary, you would still prefer immortality over mortality!" Plato stepped up, as he embraced his teacher and the two of them stepped apart, preparing to go dine in the banquet hall below.

Socrates nodded slowly. "Yes, I should expect that I would, though such a thing is surely impossible. A pipe dream born of fools. To be able to spread my wisdom everywhere, to the ends of the cosmos, until the end of time... it would not be such a bad thing."

As they walked side by side down the arm, Socrates rubbed that curious red stone on his necklace. "Truly, it would not be such a bad thing."

Part 184:

Zeus held the scroll of papyrus in front of himself with the power of telekinesis, a weak spell he had cast so he wouldn't have to use his arms.

"We're losing."

The small group of a dozen angels and gods nodded sadly, as they had already read the report.

Zeus continued. "We can't keep going on like this. Eremial made a foolish mistake recently, thinking he could simply jump into battle to save some humans. The demons slayed him in an instant."

Gabriel sighed as he laid back on the ground, staring up at the ceiling with empty eyes. "Well, at the least, the demons aren't winning either. The humans seem to be crushing them soundly."

Raphael slowly tapped a ball back and forth on the table in front of himself. "A hollow victory. Remember, the demons are not our only enemies. If the demons were to be wiped out, the humans would come for us next. It might take them a few millennia to find us and attack us, but with our current numbers, we would surely lose."

A nearby angel raised her hand up slightly. "I mean no disrespect, Raphael, but are you actually implying we should simply stay out of human affairs, or worse, give aid to the demons so they don't die off?"

"No, Uzziel. I'm saying we must find a way to quickly replenish our numbers. Eventually humans or demons will win this war, and humans are definitely the more likely thanks to their rapidly evolving technology and their Heroes. No matter what it takes, we must come up with some way to supplement or greatly increase our numbers. If we do not, when one of the other two wins, we will surely die next."

Uzziel hesitated. "I understand what you're saying, but even with humanity's greater numbers, what good are swords and bows against the powers of one who can move at the speed of light, or one who can shoot massive rays of light that kill an enemy in an instant? Could the humans really ever pose a threat?"

Gabriel interrupted, tilting his head to the side to look at her. "Let's be clear about one thing, I am certainly powerful, but my ultimate attack has virtually no effect on any but the most vile of humans. It was originally crafted inside of myself to slay demons, and to make sure that its

power does not harm my allies. Since humans were originally the allies of angel-kind, I would surely be almost useless in a battle against their species."

Raphael rolled his ball back and forth slowly as he nodded. "Indeed, but moreso than that, even with Gabriel's awe inspiring power, even if he could kill thousands of humans at once, I have... *seen* what humans will become. In a dream I had recently, I have forseen what a threat they will become to not just our kind, but the universe as a whole. They are the species with the most latent power waiting to be unleashed."

Zeus rapped his knuckles softly on the arm of his massive marble chair. "To be honest, I still find it difficult to understand how humans who lag so far behind demons in evolutionary ability, and lifespan, can defeat demons that had lived for hundreds, even thousands of years. The demons must surely be very battle hardened, swift, strong, coordinated, agile... having not directly witnessed one of these battles myself, I should like to hear how they are doing it."

Gabriel coughed slightly. "I will explain, my liege. Actually, it is a simple matter. The human with a short lifespan possesses three main advantages over a demon. Firstly, the human expects to lose, while the demons expects to win. A human fighting a terrifying monster fights more cautiously, while a demon fights more brazenly. Thus, demons tend to make more mistakes during an act of combat."

"Secondly, because humans live such short lives, they have developed a strange unspoken creed. 'Better to die on the field of battle, than at home in a warm bed.' Because of this, they fight knowing they will die someday anyway, putting in monstrous efforts to overcome their foes while the demons let their guards down due to overconfidence."

"But thirdly, and most damningly, the humans are far, far more brilliant than we give them credit for. The strongest, most intelligent, and most powerful humans breed the most, creating a form of elite warriors that pass the art of war down to their descendants. And even moreso, the intelligence of the average human, specifically when it comes to learning an enemy's weakness and strategizing on the fly, is unparalleled."

Gabriel took a small breath. "We angels and gods have a real vulnerability just waiting to be exploited by an intrepid human or group of them. We do not fight often. A human's entire life is fighting, whether verbal, mental, or physical. They fight constantly, whether they fight each other, their own thoughts, their emotions, their ideals, their religions... and speaking of which, we may have made a small mistake by making humans fight amongst themselves over religion. By doing this, we have given rise to massive battles spanning thousands, even hundreds of thousands of warriors. Each one is recorded and taught to students of war later on. They hone their skills daily."

Raphael stared at the ball he rolled back and forth with unfocused eyes. "Aye. Humans are almost enviable, in a way. Through their short lives, they manage to find meaning in their quickly extinguished existences."

Zeus sighed again, then waved his hand. "Let's get back to the bigger picture. We need to increase our numbers, and soon. We need a big increase in the numbers of angels up here. I want ideas. I want concrete plans. If the Creator made angels, there must be a loophole somewhere so we can have more."

Raphael and Gabriel sat silently as they thought. Uzziel broke the silence. "Well, we still have the Beacon of Life, correct? Perhaps, using the souls it has collected, we could fashion angels out of the ones that passed long ago?"

Zeus felt his face contort slightly, as he pondered the idea. "It... doesn't seem possible. Maybe. Maybe not. We should have to look into it."

From the far side of the long table, one who had been quiet for the entire meeting spoke up. *Michael*, the Divine King. "Zeus. I usually have little to say, but if you would hear me out, I have an idea."

Everyone at the table turned to look at him. "Hmm? What might that be? It's rare for you to offer unsolicited words, Michael."

Michael stared ahead stonily. "I have a suggestion that involves not just the Beacon of Life, but an appropriate sacrifice, plus a certain set of conditions. I am roughly ninety percent sure it would work, and our forces would be bolstered dramatically."

Zeus leaned in intently. "You don't say..."

The *Resurrection Project* was under way.

Part 185:

The democratically recognized leader of the Republic of Rome stood atop his veranda, addressing his citizens.

"My people! I have come today to deliver an address based on the state of our mighty nation! For almost seven hundred years, since the founding of our capital city, we have fought and bled to spread the vastness of our republic!"

Julius Caesar addressed the tens of thousand of people below him, who occasionally roared in applause to his words.

"We have crushed many of our enemies, we have gained incredible wealth and power, we have become an unstoppable force in the world! We are truly a nation blessed by the gods on high! But, we must be wary. Enemies lurk among us."

The crowd quieted down as they listened intently.

"I have received news that demons are in our midst. Vile creatures with unholy abominable powers, they seek to destroy us and our way of life. They may look like you, or you, or even you, but they are not human, make no mistake." Julius pointed to various members of the crowd as he spoke.

"The demons have one goal, which is to eradicate all humans. And we have the goal of eradicating them! I have heard in whispers that some people believe the demons do not truly even exist, or that the gods are myths and legends. These rumors are completely false! The gods bless us from on high, and the demons curse at us from below the boots of our troops!"

Caesar pounded his fist onto the balcony as he yelled. "We have enemies to the north, the east, the west, and the south, but the most insidious enemy is not one who attacks at our gates, but one who attacks from within our midst, in our hearts and minds! The worst enemy is one who whispers doubts about the might of our republic's army, and who speaks ill of the leaders, who have the best intentions for the good of their people at heart!"

Behind Caesar, standing further back in the doorway, unseen, his young protege watched from the shadows. *Brutus*.

* * *

Brutus left the balcony, as his mentor and *friend* made his speech. "Strong words for a weak willed dictator." He muttered to himself quietly as he walked. Once he had left the room Caesar was speaking from, a woman approached him quietly, falling into stride beside him.

"Caesar thinks he knows everything, but he's not as smart or as brave as you, Brutus." The beautiful woman dressed herself in concealing robes, but even so, the figure her body cut was difficult to miss. Brutus, however, was not a man easily swayed by the figure of any woman. He had more important matters to attend to.

"Pretty words, from a demon wench. Belial, I know you have your own desires, and I know you say you defected from the demons, but I find your words difficult to believe. You will help me achieve my goals, and only then will I help you with yours." Belial tried to reach out and lock her arm around his, but he swatted her away.

Belial puffed out her face in a fake display of sadness. "Oh Brutus, if only you could understand the heart of a poor forsaken woman who simply wishes to have some love in her life."

Brutus felt his stomach physically roil. "Calm yourself, I only partner with demons because I must. Now quiet down, we will be meeting with General Pompey soon."

They turned around a corner and entered a room that held a small table. Pompey and his beautiful wife, Metella, sat waiting at the marble table. "Brutus! So good to see you!" Pompey stood up, and quickly approached the two of them. Embracing Brutus with a hug, Brutus' entire demeanor changed as he smiled and grinned at the general.

"Ah, Pompey, I'd like to introduce you to a mistress of mine! Her name is Belial, she's a lovely lady!" Brutus' entire grim expression had changed to an incredibly deceptive smile. *Humans certainly know how to fake their emotions just as well as any demon could.* Belial found herself thinking about this quietly.

Pompey raised an eye slightly. "And... does your wife, Portia, know of this?"

Brutus grinned broadly. "Portia was the one who *suggested* it!" He nudged Pompey in the ribs a little bit and Pompey guffawed, returning the nudge.

Belial found herself fighting the urge to roll her eyes. *Humans, especially men, are so simple.*

The older general beckoned to the table and the three of them took their seats. "Pompey, it is good to see that you have returned from your conquests in the east. What are your plans now?" Brutus started off the conversation with a fairly neutral question, as they began digging in and enjoying the lavish meal servants were delivering. Chicken, lamb, fruits and vegetables, expensive cutlery and silverware, it was a small meal, yet fit for a king.

Pompey felt the grin fall from his face. "Yes, I have just gotten back, but there is much to do. I sense much unrest in this empire. For every victory of mine, I gain five enemies in the Senate.

I am fortunate to have you and Julius as my friends, otherwise my name would not be so easily recorded in the annals of history."

Metalla leaned over and nudged Pompey with her shoulder. "Tell him about Egypt!"

He paused as he thought about it. "Every source has told me that Egypt is slowly falling into disarray. It is no longer a great empire as it were hundreds of years ago. Given a chance, I should like to make it my next conquest, though matters at home may make that impossible for the near future."

Brutus nodded. "Egypt under Roman control? It seems a pipe dream, yet I find it a compelling promise. Would you be able to do it? To defeat those who rule over Egypt?"

Pompey kept his expression blank. "Perhaps, perhaps not. Beyond asking if I could defeat the Egyptians, I have more pressing concerns. I feel something dark is falling upon Rome."

The demon female found herself quietly glancing away, as if to not draw Pompey's attention. Brutus responded. "Something dark? What could you mean?"

"Simply put, I feel a plot brewing. Too many in the senate fear Julius' current influence. They would make our friend the political enemy instead of a grand leader. They fear his power so much they might even do something drastic."

Belial and Brutus both stifled chuckles and kept themselves from glancing at each other. "Surely you don't mean... a coup?"

Pompey grimaced. "Or worse. I have no sources on this, it is but a hunch, but I fear a civil war might be brewing."

Brutus nodded as he took in the information, and a bite of meat. "I understand. I am glad you brought your worries to my attention. You are... a good friend of Julius's."

The meal continued on for a while as the four of them spoke off and on, about politics, intrigue, and even just a bit of banter.

A few years later, Brutus would go on to murder his mentor, shortly after Pompey was assassinated. Rome would never again be the same, nor would humanity.

Part 186:

The young man carefully tapped the chisel with his hammer, slowly carving off bits of wood. He was sweating a little bit, but nothing unlike what he had already dealt with.

The work was slow, but steady-going. As he shaped the wood, the chair he was creating slowly took shape. It was plain, like the clothes he wore, but it had a special *something* to it. Love, hard work, and attention to details were some of the many reasons he and his father were popular craftsmen in his village.

His father walked into the humble shop, crafted by his own hands a few years earlier. "Ah, it's comin' along pretty well, boy. Mary's gonna love it!"

His dad patted him on the back, and then walked over to take his own seat. "King Herod has ordered me to make more implements of punishment, as he usually does. I want you to finish up with that chair, take it in to your mother, and leave me here for a few hours."

The young boy nodded quietly, as he continued chiseling at the chair. "Just a few more minutes, father."

Dad watched quietly as his son finished up his chair, then he quietly got up and left without saying a word.

I wonder if what my wife said was really true. A virginal conception? Who ever has heard of it? But her chastity was pure...

Joseph turned back to begin work on the wooden cross. Another one for the king, orders were orders.

* * *

Mary turned around as she saw her son walk in the house. "Jesus, is that the chair you were making for me?" Her son nodded and smiled as he quietly pulled up the chair and pushed it in to the table.

"Do you mind if I sit in it?" Mary smiled as Jesus nodded again. She sat down and was pleased by the concave shape for the seat. "It's made of wood, yet so comfortable!"

Jesus walked over and sat on his own smaller chair he had crafted a few months ago. "Mother, is it time for the passover festival yet?" He reached over and grabbed a sharp knife and piece of wood so he could carve drawings while he sat down.

Mary paused. "I'm sorry, Jesus, but it won't be here for another two weeks. I do know how you love to go."

Jesus nodded quietly as he sat and carved. He had a feeling that he was no ordinary child, yet something inside of him seemed to prevent him from digging any deeper. All he knew was that inside temples of worship, he felt much different than he did here at home. Something was calling to him, but he could not quite put his hand on it. Perhaps, when he was older, he would understand.

* * *

After a few hours, Jesus was in bed, nearly falling asleep when he heard his father enter the house. It was dark out, so Joseph must have been out cutting the tool for Herod late into the night. He could hear his mother and father speaking quietly in the living room. How he was able to hear words so clearly, and think so clearly, especially at such a young age, it frankly mystified him.

"He's asking about the passover festival again." Mary whispered, but Jesus heard. "I worry about him, you know. He's so smart for such a young boy."

Joseph sighed. "What about the dream I had shortly after he was born? Could it have been real?"

Mary stared at him silently for a few moments. "Perhaps. It is not in our hands anymore. It is up to the gods, or god, or whoever rules over us."

Joseph smiled sweetly at his wife. "Come now, the other boys will be back soon from their trip. Let's prepare their beds. We should leave this idle talk in the past."

Mary nodded as the two of them quickly got up and headed into the shared bedroom for the boys.

Jesus simply pretended he was fast asleep.

Part 187: Son Of Man

It had taken him many years, but it was finally here. As his friend John dipped him under the water, Jesus arose out of the shimmering flowing pool and saw a beautiful white sparkle of light, almost resembling a dove, quickly and silently fly into his body, absorbing into his soul.

In an instant, everything changed.

Billions of years of memories flooded inside his skull, as all his angelic conquests came rushing into his mind. He was here for a reason. He was here to make a difference.

He thanked John, and stepped out of the river. John mentioned that he had two comrades who might join Jesus on his mission.

Jesus left after that, thinking carefully about what was next to come.

* * *

He spoke loudly to the people listening all around him. "You have heard that it was said, 'Love your neighbor and hate your enemy.' But I tell you, love your enemies and pray for those who persecute you, that you may be children of your Father in heaven. He causes his sun to rise on the evil and the good, and sends rain on the righteous and the unrighteous. If you love those who love you, what reward will you get? Are not even the tax collectors doing that?"

A man nearby spoke up. "But, great priest, Jesus, what of the demons? Are not the demons our mortal enemy?"

Jesus turned to him. "The demons, they are true evil. They seek to take man from the path of good, whispering fear and doubt into his heart. Make no mistake, the demons are the worst beings in the world. However, if a demon should repent of his or her evil ways, you must forgive them. Forgiveness is hardest to do when one has done the unforgivable, but as followers of the Word of God, you must always be ready and willing."

The people around him nodded sagely as he continued on. "Be careful not to practice your righteousness in front of others to be seen by them. If you do, you will have no reward from your Father in heaven..."

* * *

Jesus lacked the power that he had once possessed as the archangel, but a small remnant still found itself inside his human form. He stared out over the stormy sea, as a boat tossed and turned in the distance. If he did not go out there, his apostles would likely die.

The Sea of Galilee, it was really just a gigantic lake, but to a boat stuck out in the middle of it during a terrible storm, it might as well have been an ocean.

The wind howled and thunder cracked, as Jesus quietly cast a spell, aiming at his feet. Levitation, a weakened form allowing him to easily walk on the waters. With his very weak abilities, this would be trivial.

Jesus quietly walked out in the middle of the raging storm, as small waves caused by the terrible winds swept across his feet, threatening to bring him down. What he was doing now would be considered a great miracle by people who had witnessed it, but in truth it was less than 1% of what he had originally been capable of.

His original form was locked up in heaven sealed inside a ring for safekeeping. He now was merely a shadow of his former self. But in return for the path he must walk, he would be the one to save the angels, and humans. It was a sacrifice worth making.

Jesus walked out onto the great lake, and on the boat he approached, his apostle Peter gasped as he saw his lord draw near. "What madness is this?! The great teacher walks atop the waters as a god! Surely, everything he has preached is true!"

Jesus smiled, his expression barely visible amidst the roaring winds and crazed waters. "Peter. My apostle. Come out to me."

Peter gaped openly. Jesus stood nearly a hundred feet away from the boat, out amidst the crazed waters. "My lord, surely you jest?! I cannot walk on water as you do!"

Jesus knew, the only way man would ever be able to truly defeat the demons, not the ones in the world, but the ones in their heart, would be to unlock the powers hidden inside them. "Peter, you of little faith, why do you doubt me? Come." Jesus quickly moved his hands as he cast a spell on Peter's feet. The spell would only work if Peter consciously used his own inner spiritual energy.

Peter steeled himself as he stepped off the boat, cursing silently in his mind. To his astonishment, he was able to step foot on the waters, and gingerly, he walked over to his teacher, somehow ignoring the maelstrom blowing upon himself.

"I'm... I'm doing it!" He gasped as he looked up at Jesus, but at that moment, his attention wavered, and his heart jumped into his throat as he fell into the water. Before he could fall past his knees, Jesus was upon him, covering the distance in a moment's notice. Peter had been too scared to notice, but Jesus had moved inhumanly fast, far faster than a mere flesh and bones body should be able to.

"Why did you let your concentration slip? Did you experience doubt, or perhaps overconfidence? Pride goes before the fall." Jesus helped him back up to the ship. As Jesus stepped onto the boat, he glared up at the sky. Waving his hands in the air, he yelled out loud.

" SILENCE! "

As his hands finished casting the spell, his words seemed to almost instantly end the storm.

The other men on the ship gasped as they witnessed this spectacle. "Who is this man, that the winds and waves should obey his will?"

Peter stared at the man who was looking up at the sky stoically. "He is the son of god, the one known as Christ and Jesus. He is the one who will save our people."

* * *

Jesus ignored the looks of the men around him, as he walked forwards, carrying his cross on his back. Peter stood atop a nearby building, watching in silence, as tears poured down his face. *As my teacher predicted, I forsook him in his most dire hour. I, who witnessed the greatest spectacle of all time, ignored him and pretended to not know him. It is my own fault that he walks these streets.*

In another part of the city, a man named Judas snickered evilly as he took the thirty pieces of silver. When he walked away from the ones giving him his reward, he quietly pulled out a small transmission orb. "Satan, it is done as you wished. We have set up the archangel to be killed. He will not be able to convert any more humans to the side of the angels. Their thought energy will be cut off before they grow too strong."

A mental image of Satan's face appeared in the man's mind. "Good. It almost seems too easy, like he wanted to be killed, but no matter. With him out of the picture, our power will only be able to grow further. Our influence among the humans has grown quite large as of late. Even the kings of Judea bow to our will."

Judas nodded, as he scratched his skin. *Oops, my red skin is returning. Better cast a bit of illusion to make sure nobody notices.* Judas quickly cast his magic to hide his true form as he tucked the orb back inside a pocket. His next goal was to make a dramatic exit and pretend to kill himself so he might return to his true master's side.

Jesus continued walking through the town, finally arriving with his cross at the place where he would be left to die. Two other men were already here, slowly moving their own instruments of torture to the correct position so they could be nailed to it. Their guards didn't rush them, as they derived no pleasure from watching other men die slow agonizing deaths, not even criminal scum like these three.

Unlike the others though, Jesus quickly lined his cross up on the ground, surprising some of the guards who watched. "Almost like he *desires* a quick death." One guard remarked to another.

Jesus quickly, too quickly even, laid himself across the implement, stretching his arms out. He looking knowingly at the guard who had whispered from before. "Do it."

The guard gaped, but then shrugged. "It's on your conscience, not mine." This was how he had managed to explain away the guilt of his chosen profession, by blaming it on those who were to die.

As the guard pounded the nails into Jesus wrists, he marveled that the man did not scream aloud or cry, he merely flinched and gritted his teeth as the nails were driven into his flesh. The other two were quick to follow, though their screams were agonizing to hear.

Finally, the moment of truth. All three were raised up at the same time, as blood gushed and flowed freely from their wrists and feet. The two men on either side of Jesus wept and cried aloud, begging for forgiveness, but Jesus stoically bit his lip until it bled, keeping silent.

The guards stared in amazement at the power of the man they were witnessing. *This one is not like the others*, they found themselves thinking. Finally, they walked away a short distance into a nearby tent. It was the last reprieve of the accused, to die alone, so none would have to watch their pitiful last moments.

As the sharp pain subsided, and only dull, awful throbbing pain remained, along with a long slow painful death, one of the men turned to Jesus. "You... you're the one they call the King of the Jews, is that right?"

Jesus nodded as he stared ahead silently.

"I... I am a sinner. A thief. A terrible man. I did many things that I now regret... am I impossible to forgive? Have I become irredeemable?" The man looked at Jesus, his last moments upon him, but eager for a modicum of forgiveness.

Jesus turned and stared back at the man, his eyes betraying no emotion. "Truly, I say to you, you will be with me in Paradise." Jesus looked up into the clouds. "It... it is done."

The moment he said those words, there was a bright flash of light that emanated from his body for but a split moment. His body sank on the cross, as his flesh corpse sagged in its place. The thief gasped openly. "Guards! Guards!"

The guards came running out of their tent, only to see a pitiful sight. "Ah, what is it, thief? Have you no shame? Must you continue to beg with your last words?"

The thief protested. "No! That man! A light came out of his body!"

One of the guards shoved the others out of the way, as a strange redness seemed to appear in his eyes. "Did you see something?"

The thief nodded with what little energy he had left. "Yes! He was dying but at the last moment, he- KUHH!" Before the thief could finish his sentence, the guard jumped forwards impaling the thief in the chest. The thief watched with his last breath as the redness in the guard's eyes disappeared and they became a normal color again. Then... his vision went white.

* * *

Suddenly, the thief gasped! He was alive! Not only alive, but surrounded by whiteness all over the place as far as his eyes could see.

In front of him, the son of man stood once again. "Congratulations, thief. You have been reborn. Welcome, to paradise. Your faith in the end was what saved you."

The thief stared around himself in awe. Was this... *Heaven?*

Jesus turned and vanished, as his body instantly reappeared in front of Zeus. Kneeling down on the ground, he spoke five simple words. "The resurrection project... is complete."

* * *

The guard stared at the body of the son of man. Unlike the thief who had poured blood from his wound, the King of Jews, as it were, was bleeding water from his stab wound. The guard slowly pulled out the spear as he stared back and forth between the two bodies.

What could it mean? He would have to contact Satan to tell him of this unexpected news.

Part 188:

"The army of heaven is expanding rapidly." Zeus stared at the numbers. "Two million in just a few years. This is unprecedented."

Gabriel nodded as he held Michael's ring in his hands. Michael had 99% of his spirit energy and personality stored here for safekeeping, all part of the plan. Michael's actual body had died during combat with demons shortly afterwards, leaving them to think an important archangel had perished.

However, he had not, as he was safely stored for a future hero's use. "This system truly works out in our favor. The humans are weak, but they make for a good disposable fighting force, and when they die, they become loyal subservient angels, bound to the will of whatever god is king, forever. Their abilities are enhanced, though not nearly as strong as a regular angel's power, and they continue to be powerful pawns afterwards."

Zeus nodded quietly as Raphael spoke. "Essentially, while alive, humans who give their lives to us give us thought energy which boosts our spirit energy, and since they can't make use of it anyway it doesn't harm them. While alive they fight each other and eventually the demons, but when they die, they are added to our ranks, greatly increasing our fighting forces and numbers. On top of that, it works no matter which gods they worship, just so long as they worship a god."

Uzziel rapped a finger on her lips thoughtfully. "That's fine and all, but what of the atheists? There are many humans who don't ascribe belief to any particular god, and some who don't worship the gods at all."

Zeus shrugged. "They are truly useless in our grand scheme of things, but in the end, their numbers are small. So long as they don't grow too big in number, we will continue to bolster our ranks."

Uzziel took a sip of a strange golden drink. "All right. But explain to me again, how does the actual conversion process work? What are the requirements for the process to work in order for humans to become angels?"

Gabriel slid a piece of paper over to her. "It's quite simple, really. A human has to worship a specific god, or gods, or set of religious beliefs that point to a specific god. So long as that person dies a believer, and so long as there is a King of Gods currently in power, they will be reborn in heaven as a Neo-Angel. That's really all there is to it. In fact, if humanity gets into an all-out war with the demons and 99% of them die, as they are now, they can fight twice on the battlefield,

and the second time around they will be ten times stronger than they were before once reborn as an angel."

Raphael stared at the paper Gabriel had slid towards Uzziel, but he was not reading it. He was merely staring ahead blankly. "I see just one or two flaws in the plan. The first is mass atheism. Should that happen, heaven's numbers would slow to a crawl. The second is an assassination of Zeus and whoever might replace him afterwards. If the demons can keep killing off the King, they would be able to stop the humans from rebirthing as angels. Despite all of this though, we seem to have created an impenetrable wall of numbers."

Uzziel stared at the paper blankly. "Aren't we... invincible now? If we send the humans out to kill as many demons as possible, many humans and demons will die. Then we send in the reborn humans to polish off whoever's left... we win the war."

"We can't do that." Gabriel cut her off. "We require thought energy to live, or have you forgotten? In fact, too many humans in heaven as angels could be a detriment, since the amount of thought energy we receive would be spread out dramatically. If all the humans on Earth are killed, the demons will still win since all they would have to do is wait us out. Archangels have enough energy stored to live for a few eons without dying, but all the lesser angels would die out within a few years. The demons have three victory conditions, but we still have to maintain the status quo to survive, no matter what. And as for the humans? If they eradicate the demons, and then come for us, or if they then become mass atheists, we lose either way."

Uzziel sighed. "You would think being an all-powerful angel would give you an advantage, but I'm beginning to wonder if we're not the weakest of the three races."

Zeus nodded. "Angels are not that strong, to be honest. An average god descended from Titans is far stronger, but an angel possesses a much higher capacity for raw power. As an example, to be blunt, Gabriel is the most powerful being in heaven, thanks to storing a colossal amount of spiritual energy. However, if he were to expend a massive amount of it in battle, he would surely be weaker than I, who can actually regenerate my own energy in much the same way a human does. Gabriel is actually my superior for raw power, but my inferior in average power."

The female angel cracked her neck as she leaned back. "So, what next? What do we do now that we have initiated the resurrection project?"

Gabriel began pacing around in his shrunken body. "The simple answer is that we need to start making a lot of humans very religious, get them to make many children, get them to fight and die in wars, and also get them to kill demons. However, something has been bothering me a lot lately."

"Hm? Bothering *you*? What could be such a problem that you would be worried about it?" Zeus' eyes followed Gabriel as he paced back and forth.

"It's the demons. Their movements as of late are erratic. Ever since the faked death of Michael, they seem to be coming out a lot less often. If they were to wise up and go into hiding, we could continue to get the humans to fight amongst themselves for religious wars, but without an external enemy that would merely last a few thousand, or even a few hundred years. Humans have notoriously short memories. Without constant reminder of the presence of demons, they would soon forget they even exist, relegating demons to myths and legends. And what if, while the humans are killing one another, the unified demonic front builds up their forces and attacks out of the blue? Humanity could die all too easily."

Uzziel sighed deeply. "This seems hopeless. The demons and humans have so many ways they could win, we have none. What is even the point anymore? Isn't there some distant world we could travel to and make some weak willed apes our minions? Maybe we should just take over the human's minds, force all of them to become our subservient followers."

Zeus shrugged. "We've tried. However, the Creator placed an edict on the universe, preventing one from invading another's free will and controlling them. Trust me, if I could take over the minds of the humans, I would have done so already."

Uzziel stared at an empty spot on the wall. "It truly is hopeless, isn't it?"

Raphael smiled slightly. "Yes, child. Now you understand. It truly *is* hopeless. You are becoming wiser every day."

Part 189: Deus Ex

April, 1776.

The well dressed man tapped his cigar on the edge of the podium, as he adjusted his suit and tie while staring at the small crowd.

"Demons are real."

A few in the front row leaned forwards as they furrowed their brows. "Demons, huh? You expect us to believe that load of kookery?" One of the men was clearly unimpressed by the revelation. "I thought you brought us here to talk about important things, Johann."

"This is important, Mr. Ferdinand. This explains everything. All the mysteries, all the problems that plague society. Demons are real, and I aim to prove it." Johann stared intently at the man in the audience as he spoke.

Ferdinand rolled his eyes. "Yes, of course. Demons, then angels and gods and everything else! Do you expect us to believe this tomfoolery?"

Johann nodded quietly. "Yes... I do expect you to. You have to understand, mankind is being controlled. We're being run by a great evil. If we can find proof of the demons and their existence, we will find the one who rules us."

Johann closed his eyes for a moment before speaking again. "On my honor, as Johann Adam Weishaupt, I swear to you, everything I'm about to say today is true. None of this is lies, or fiction. All of it is backed by ancient manuscripts from thousands of years ago. I have actual writings from those who followed the first saints, from those who spoke of meeting angels and demons, and I have personally spoken to rulers of the world living today. They all point to one thing: Humanity is just a pawn in a grand game, a game that will end with only one of the three species being the victor in the greatest war of our time."

Ferdinand listened silently, but another man in the audience scoffed. "War? The only major wars I know of are those Brits and their damned colonies, having a little spat over who gets to control the bloody land! There are a couple other wars in Austria, Prussia, and a few others, but those are all relatively minor! You're out of your mind!" The man stood up in a huff and stomped out of the room, flailing his hands around as he slammed the door shut behind himself.

Johann cleared his throat. "That was pleasant. However, Simon was wrong. We have a much bigger war to worry about. Humanity is being played for fools by those up on high, and those

below us. We're treated as nothing more than tools in a grand game of chess. We're being *used* as bait by the angels, and slaughtered quietly by the demons. We're made to fight amongst each other in great religious wars, then used as tools of war when we die. Our lives have no meaning beyond fueling the bloodthirstiness of the two supreme powers."

Ferdinand snickered. "Well, if gods and devils are real, then what hope does man have? How could we be anything but mere pigs to the slaughter?"

The man at the podium had an expression of annoyance cross his face. "If you'd pipe down, I'd be happy to tell you. The solution is so simple, yet it will be so difficult to carry out, that it will make your ears bleed when you hear it. All we have to do is make people stop following all religion, and that will take care of the angels, then we use our superior weaponry to destroy the demons, and then we rule the world. Easy!"

Ferdinand stared evenly at Johann. "That doesn't sound simple. At all. What makes you think the demons will be so easy to kill?"

Johann stepped down from the podium as the small crowd watched in silence. He walked up to just a few feet away from Ferdinand. "One of the documents I recovered detailed the Crusades. They were not about what history has said they were about. All of it was a farce. We drove out the demons from Europe and cleansed the country of their filth. However, in truth, the crusaders were led by a very special individual."

"Who might that be?" Ferdinand stared into Johann's eyes. "Go on, I'm listening."

Johann paused. "I don't know her name, to be honest. But what I do know is the crusaders were secretly led by a woman, and she was a person gifted with a power from heaven known as the Hero's Soul."

Ferdinand snorted. "A woman? Back in those days? Be realistic, if you're going to tell a tall tale, at least try to actually convince me of its truth."

The other man felt a wave of annoyance pass over him. "We're talking about demons, angels, and gods, yet you think the most surprising thing here is that it was a woman who led the crusades? For the love of- get your head on straight!" Johann took a long puff off his cigar, which he had neglected for the last few minutes. It glowed red hot as he inhaled and then exhaled. "The most important thing here is the power of the Hero. I believe we can harness it. It can be our ultimate weapon in this great war. We simply have to find a candidate who would receive it."

Another man nearby, Dukakis was his name, spoke out. "What is this Hero Soul you're going on about? What does it do?"

Johann sniffled. *Finally, someone with an open mind.* "The hero's soul is something that transfers the moment a hero dies, it reincarnates in the body of another. I don't know the exact details, but I've learned of it through various... contacts. If we can snatch it for ourselves, it will give us not just power to kill demons, angels, and gods, but power to influence the world."

The only woman in the room, Elise, spoke up next. "So if this thing is so powerful, surely there must be a way to find it? Perhaps tracing the lineage of the heroes from the past? Maybe we could predict which of their heirs will inherit it next."

Johann waved his hand at her. "Nay, it would not work. It appears here and there, randomly. Sometimes it's based on how an individual looks, sometimes it's their personality, or something else, but it does not stay within a specific bloodline. To be honest, I haven't the damndest clue on how to approach it or how to locate the Hero, if they are findable in the first place."

Ferdinand lifted his hand and opened his mouth to speak, but at that moment, a bell went off in the front of the room.

"Ah, it would seem our time is up. Friends, I want to thank you for coming here, and of course we will all meet up next week." Johann glanced at Ferdinand, knowingly. "I'm sure some of you will have pressing questions to attend to, but until the time has come, let our questions stay dormant. We don't want prying ears to hear us speak, now do we?"

Ferdinand swallowed as he quietly got up from his chair and shuffled towards the door.

"Don't forget the pledge!" Elise piped up cheerfully.

The people in the room paused from their standing up and turned back to the front of the room, as they stared at the engaved image of a pyramid with an all-seeing eye at the top. All of them immediately spoke in unison.

" I pledge myself to account the good of the Order as my own, and am ready to serve it with my fortune, my honor, and my blood. Should I, through omission, neglect, passion, or wickedness, behave contrary to this good of the Order, I subject myself to what reproof or punishment my Superiors shall declare. The friends and enemies of the Order shall be my friends and enemies; and with respect to both I will conduct myself as directed by the Order, and am ready, in every lawful way, to devote myself to its increase and promotion, and therein to employ all my ability. All this I promise, and protest, without secret reservation, according to the intention of the Society which requires from me this engagement. "

The first members of the *Illuminati* picked up their belongings and headed out the door, as they entered the quiet streets of Ingolstadt.

Part 190:

"...The Illuminati? Seriously? You've got to be kidding." I stared at Samantha in disbelief. "You've definitely gone too far, you're pulling my leg."

Samantha pouted. "I'm not lying! The humans became smarter and realized the gods were toying with them... they started up secret societies to rid the world of angelic and demonic influence."

I chuckled softly. "This sounds like the plot for a bad video game. Illuminati, angels, gods, demons, humanity's fate, and maybe even aliens. What the hell happened while I was out for a hundred million years, anyway?"

I stared ahead blankly as I thought of the last 11 years I'd spent in this labyrinth. Much of that time was spent pissing into the wind, doing little other than fighting demons and killing demons. This has been my life now, for too long. Whatever this 'great war' is, it's older than mankind itself, and has stretched on for an unimaginable hundred million years or longer.

"Samantha, Cassiel, what if I told you two that I want to put an end to the war?"

Cassiel shrugged. Samantha slowly wagged her head up and down. "I suppose that would be nice. How, though? What can one man do to stop the war?"

I curved my lips into a small smile. "I'm not 'one man', though. The three of us, are one human, one angel, and one demon. We represent each of the species! And on top of that, we seem to get along splendidly. It could be like this easily, if the others would just forget their grudges and move on."

Samantha instantly shook her head. "Nope, sorry, not going to happen. Maybe the angels can, seeing as Cassiel is all that's left, and maybe the humans could too, but the demons? It will never work. Too much bad blood. Humans have left a corrupting influence on what was once the most harmonious race. Under Satan, we all followed orders and let him do the thinking. Ever since he died... we..." Samantha trailed off as she glanced away for a moment, a storm of emotions clouding her face. She quickly righted herself. "His death left us in tatters. We demons may have won the war, but now we are ruled by petty feuds, squabbling for power, and fighting over scraps and bits of land. We have become like the humans once were... or still are."

The expression on her face soured as she rubbed her bare arms. I could feel my own emotions deflating. "We need answers. I need answers." I thought back to that day, years ago... that day everything changed and I experienced true loss. "Samantha, this is going to be an odd question. Have you ever heard of a human woman named Marie?"

Samantha shrugged. "Marie? I hear many human names and forget them just as quickly, especially such a plain and boring name like that."

Makes sense. I didn't expect her to know, but Samantha seems to know a lot of things, more than I find comfortable for an ordinary demon. "I'm not sure of the details, but Marie was a woman who may know something about the Cryopod I was in when I arrived at this labyrinth. I think she was another of the cryopod survivors, or maybe she was a human who escaped from one of the world gates... I don't know, but Marie is the key. I must speak to her."

Cassiel kept quiet as she obviously had no idea who that was. "Well, Hero, do you have anything to go on?" Samantha sighed as she played with her hair, her boredom already starting to show.

I paused. "No... but, come to think of it, maybe I know someone who does."

I get up and beckon to the two girls. They get up and walk up close as I put my hands on each of their shoulders. "Brace yourselves. We're about see just how far I can stretch my abilities."

I glance at my mental map. I might be mistaken, but this one spot here looks like it's the right one...

"Teleport! "

In an instant, we travel hundreds of miles, draining a gigantic amount of my energy, as we appear inside a familiar dark room. The only visible light is the light escaping from Cassiel's aura, as I look up and spot a familiar tiny hole in the ceiling.

Oh, and we're not alone in the room.

A familiar looking statue greets me when I appear, making me jerk back for a second in fright.

"Oh, look who came to visit. It's the God King himself, along with his little pet."

Gressil.

Gressil grins at me as he notices my tiny amount of energy left over. This was... a bad idea.

Then he turned and looks at Samantha, a wave of shock passes over his face, and he bows ever so slightly. "Oh! My queen, I did not realize you were escorting these two around! Should I stay out of your way or do you have this... *situation*... under control?"

Samantha smirks as she looks away. "Do what you wish, I won't interfere."

Gressil grins as he looks down his long, pointy beak at me. "You seem to be out of energy. I'll make this quick."

Part 191:

Gressil eyeballed me, as he turned away from Samantha. "Wait, did you say queen?! Samantha, what did he mean by that?" I turned to her as I asked the question.

Gressil interjected before she could respond. "Samantha? Ha ha ha! That's not her name, imbecile! She is Belial, the second emperor of hell! The second most powerful of all the beings that live here! Show respect to my queen!"

Samantha rolled her eyes as she examined her nails. "Yeah yeah second emperor, blah blah, can you just drop it already? I'm only in that position because I'm strong, not because I rule the demons or whatever."

I openly gaped at her, my entire expression frozen in shock. "You're the second most powerful demon in all of hell?! Why are you traveling with me then? Are you spying on me?!"

She stopped looking at her nails and glared at me. "Oh for- yeah, I'm spying on you. Calm down. I could have destroyed you ten times over if I wanted to. I merely like you because I don't actually hate humans. I'm not like the other demons."

She sighed and rolled her eyes again. "Of *course* though, it does stand that I'm also no enemy of the demons, but that just means I don't care about the petty squabbles on either side."

Gressil grinned evilly. "So, my queen, if I attack this one, you won't interfere, even if I kill him?"

Belial chuckled. "Hah! You're welcome to give it a shot! I think you'll find that even with no energy, he'll still beat you hand over foot."

The smirk on Gressil's face vanished as he took a step back. "Is that... so? I had better be serious about this, then."

Gressil took a fighting stance, as he prepared some attack. Unfortunately, in the blink of an eye, something absolutely unbelievable happened.

Cassiel snapped.

"I WON'T LET YOU HURT HIM, YOU DEMON BASTARD!" Cassiel screamed in rage, which completely surprised myself and Samantha, as in the very next instant after screaming, Cassiel aimed both hands at Gressil, and fired a COLOSSAL blast of light at him. The attack surged forward at the speed of light. It wasn't even like light though, it was more of a liquid that moved at that insane speed, heated to white-hot temperatures, yet with no heat at all.

The blast came from both hands, her chest, her mouth, and both eyes, as it transformed from six individual beams, into one massive beam of devastation, as it blasted forwards, wiping Gressil off the face of the universe and plowing past the wall ahead of us, smashing through 5 straight miles before she ended the attack.

In the blink of an eye, she eradicated one I had originally felt was a grave threat only months earlier, and destroyed him with the same ease that I might swat a fly.

Cassiel gasped for breath after she ended her attack, however I was astounded to see she hadn't used even 1% of her total energy. She was out of breath simply from unleashing her emotions in a fit of rage. "Ah... I'm sorry... I just... I couldn't bear to... to look at him for another moment longer..."

She smiled thinly, but her hands were trembling violently. That attack must have been very therapeutic.

"Uh, ordinarily, he'd have survived somehow and would be coming back, right?" I glanced around but could sense nothing of his energy withing my entire spatial sight radius.

"No, that attack wiped him out quite clearly." Samantha, or rather, Belial, appeared almost bored by how easily he was destroyed. "Quite the attack, in fact, that had to be on par with Gabriel's own signature move. Possibly more powerful, considering how much it drained him compared to how little it affected you."

I took a few steps back from Belial and stood side by side with Cassiel. "We have to discuss this, Belial. If you're truly the second emperor, or empress, or whatever, then doesn't that make us mortal enemies or something?"

"Ugh, *please* don't call me Belial. I hate that name. It's not cute at all. If you can't stomach calling me by my human name, at least call me Lilia. It's so much prettier. It's what... it's what Satan used to call me in private, you know." She tossed her hair back as she stared at us with a bored expression on her face.

"All right, I'll call you Samantha then. Why did you change your name? Why are you helping me, or at least traveling along with me? Why are you... not helping out your kind? Why-"

She cut me off. "Oh for devil's sake, cut the questions. Listen, Hero, this may come as a shock to you, but I really genuinely like you, you know. I haven't liked being a part of the demons since that spoiled little... that little... *grah!*" She snarled a little bit as images of Amelia, likely killing Satan, flooded her mind, before she returned to normal a few moments later. "I haven't liked them since Satan was killed, you understand? Satan was the only reason I existed. Since his death, I have had no purpose. I don't care about the new ruler at all, he is not Satan and I will never love him."

I paused as I stared at her. "Do you know who the new ruler is? The first emperor of hell?"

She smirked. "Maybe I do, maybe I don't. I'm not going to tell you anyway, because truthfully, I don't know. Even if I did, on my honor as a demon, even one fed up with her kind, I wouldn't. But I left the ranks shortly after Satan's death. The others kept trying to delegate me positions and work but I simply don't care. Diablo and whoever can play with their little toys."

I was feeling pretty stunned by all these revelations. Samantha was the second emperor of hell. Another question came to my mind. "Samantha, Lilia, Belial... whatever you wish to be called... I just have one more question for you."

She stared at me quietly. "...What? Spit it out."

"Do you, um, do you love me?" A simple question, but her cheeks seemed to flush as she quickly turned her head away. Mine did too.

"Well, that is to say, I mean as it stands, well, when I compare you to Satan, you're clearly not his equal, but even beyond that there's the matter of our species, but let's also not forget the um..." She trailed off as her voice quieted down. "...Yes. I do... though not as strongly as I did Satan. Despite being a mere mortal, you have some qualities that he once lacked, and you have your own virtues. You're a different beast entirely..."

Great, she's comparing me to her ex-boyfriend. I don't know whether to feel complimented or insulted. Still, she seems honest. I walk over to her and wrap my arms around her. "All right... that's all I wanted to know. I love you and Cassiel both, regardless of the differences we share, because 'opposites attract' as a wise human once said."

I beckoned and Cassiel came over, the emotions from earlier having left her, as we all shared a group embrace.

"I wasn't kidding." I said, as we finally stepped apart. "I want to end this war. Maybe then, once we've all settled our issues, we can move on. But for now, let's stay together, and face the challenges together."

Samantha nodded quietly. "That would... be fine."

As we all sat there, looking back and forth at each other, I could feel a new emotion emerging. *Determination*. I have to solve the issues. I have to find out what happened to create this place. I have to know what caused the great war, and how I might solve it, hopefully without bloodshed.

I turned to the doorway Cassiel had blasted five miles deep into the labyrinth. "You've certainly got a lot of power inside of yourself."

Cassiel blushed. "Oh, um, yeah. Let's pretend that never happened, all right?"

I shrugged. "Not a big deal. And this may actually turn out to be useful. You're quickly becoming the nuclear firepower of this team, you know."

Cassiel stared at me quizzically. "Nuclear firepower? What is that?"

Hmm? She doesn't know? Maybe she was born in a time long after nuclear energy was outmoded or something. "It's nothing, it's like a really explosive type of energy, very volatile, but very powerful."

As she smiled at me, I could feel something turning in my head. Nuclear energy, huh? Nuclear energy... I'll have to think about that one.

I turned my head up to look at the ceiling. "All right, let's contact the lizardmen. Perhaps they can give us a clue on how to find Marie."

Samantha stared up at the hole too. "Marie? Who was that again?"

Sigh.

Part 192:

I stared up at the hole in the ceiling, as Samantha and Cassiel followed my gaze. "The lizardmen should be up there. Strange that they aren't coming down."

I stared intently for almost half an hour, before finally sitting down on the ground. While I waited, I decided to create a deck of cards, explaining how to play various card games to Samantha and Cassiel. After a bunch of rounds of poker, blackjack, and some other games, I was beginning to feel restless.

"Those lizards should know I'm here. Last time I must have tripped some sensor, because they came out within a few minutes of my arrival, and now there's nothing."

I glared up at the hole. What was going on?

"Cassiel, Samantha, I'll be back. You two stay here." They shrugged and nodded as they went back to playing with the cards.

"*Shrink.*"

I collapsed my body to about 11 inches high. I was astounded at the way the ground seemed to rush up at me. Cassiel and Samantha turned to look at me. "Awww, you're so adorable!" Samantha giggled when she saw my size. *Ha ha, very funny.*

I aimed my gaze at each one of my limbs. "*Adhesive. Adhesive. Adhesive. Adhesive.*" All four of my limbs became sticky, allowing me to climb walls. I stood underneath the hole and braced myself, but then paused. "Oh, Cassiel, would you mind transferring some energy to me? I'm nearly out."

She nodded. "Sure!" Aiming her hand over at me, she gave me about 1% of her energy.

I suddenly felt like I had slept for three weeks straight. *Holy shit* she has a lot of energy stored up.

Coiling my feet, I took aim, and leaped up towards the hole.

Three things happened.

First, I misjudged my power. As it turns out, when I'm shrunken down, it condenses my power into a smaller space, making me unbelievably strong and fast.

Second, I missed the hole I was jumping at.

Third, I smashed up into the ceiling, burying myself almost ten feet deep as waves of pain washed over me.

My god, I feel like I broke my neck. Insane laughter came from below me as Samantha and Cassiel cracked up and started bellowing in laughter at my predicament. *Very goddamn funny, girls.*

I quickly heal myself, and climb out of the depression I made, as I climb back up into the correct hole that leads into the lizardman lair. I feel my cheeks flush as I pass by the view of the two girls as they are guffawing and laughing mightily. Well, at least *they* got something out of it.

As I climb up into the hole, I realize just how dark it is in here. No light escapes at all. I quickly speak a single word. " *Light.* " A light appears, glowing from my body and illuminating the tightly packed walls around me, as I climb upwards. I don't actually need the light, thanks to my spatial vision, but I do like being able to also see with my normal eyes, especially in a claustrophobic environment like this.

I climb for an hour or two, easily traveling a few miles through winding corridors. Amazingly, I no longer can follow my mental map. It does not actually display the tiny crawlspaces I'm traveling inside. This is interesting to learn.

As I crawl around, I begin to smell something... something awful. Like, the smell of burned flesh and bones. I'm not liking the smell at all, and it's giving me cold sweats.

As I climb, I begin to feel a light breeze, and soon, I emerge into a large, *very* large room.

All around me are bodies and corpses of lizardmen. Thousands of them.

As I numbly step forwards, I feel myself kick something at my feet. Looking down, I spot something very familiar. Something that makes my stomach churn mightily.

It's a boomstick bolt.

This was... my doing...?

Part 193:

I stare at the bolt at my feet. This was my doing. Humans killed the lizardmen. Why? Why did they kill my friends? Why did I not tell them to spare the lizardmen?

And also... how? How did humans arrive here? How did they manage to enter the lizard HQ? Was there a traitor? Did the humans find a regular-sized passageway that led inside?

Why did the two groups battle each other? Was there a misunderstanding? Did one or the other start the fight? I can't imagine the lizards instigating the fight. They didn't attack me, and 'Marie' is supposed to be a human friend of theirs.

I have little doubt, the humans must have started this. I just don't know *why* they did it.

As I stared down at the boomstick bolt, a voice from the other side of the room suddenly startled me, turning my blood to ice for a second. "Enjoying the view?"

I whip my head up and am astonished to see a human woman standing in the corner, amidst the bodies. I didn't even sense her, how did she-?!

"Who are you?!" I yell at her, deciding to try the direct approach, as I tend to do in situations like these.

"Can't you guess? I'm Marie. You killed my children." The woman looks to be about 60 years old, but she has long red hair, and her face seems to have aged fairly well, all things considered. She wears a... kimono? A white kimono. Why a kimono of all things? I ignore the thought.

"Marie? I found you this easily?" I spoke my thoughts aloud, feeling a tinge of regret at my brazen words.

She sneered slightly. "Fantastic, glad you found what you're looking for. And what about my children, hm?" She beckoned to the corpses at my feet. "Are you going to take responsibility?"

I found myself staring again at the bodies. "Did... any survive?"

She sneers again, this time far more pronounced. " *Of course* they did, imbecile. I wouldn't let my precious babies be slaughtered so easily. But many did not escape. Luckily, my strongest ones did, they will bring the race back from the verge of *extinction*."

She calmly walked over to me, and I could feel my nerves on edge as I gazed up at the woman towering over my shrunken form. I still could not sense her presence at all. If I was limited to only my spatial vision, I'd never be able to see her.

"I... came here to try and find you. I never expected... this." I swept my gaze over the piles of bodies around me and back up to her.

"Cheh, again, great job. You never think anything through, do you? Just give some big fancy toys to the humans, expect them to deal with problems on their own. I'll bet you don't even know the reason this place actually exists, do you?" She beckoned all around herself, apparently indicating the entire labyrinth itself.

I shook my head in shame. "No... I don't know anything, to be honest."

She rolled her eyes. "Humans lost the war, and frankly I think we deserved to lose. The demons were a far more gracious host and ruler. Unlike the angels, they didn't pit us against one another, even the truce was a fair compromise."

I paused. "The truce? How do you know all of this?"

Marie sighed quietly. "Child... I don't know how old you think I am, but I am most definitely older than you could possibly imagine. I'm the oldest human who has ever lived. I'm timeless, compared to those you know about."

Hmm? That can't be right. "You were one of the cryopod occupants though, right? One of the ten?"

She raised an eyebrow at me. "One of the *ten*? How little you know."

"There's more than ten cryopods?!" I almost let out a gasp as I take a step back.

"Of course there are. You apparently were one of the original cryopod candidates. Cryotek put thousands of people in pods, shipping them to various places. However, I think you're mistaking me for someone... *ordinary*. I was not *placed* in a cryopod, I *put myself* in one."

She shrugged. "Voluntarily, at the end of the war. All part of the truce. To be honest, I don't know why I'm even telling you this. If you come with me though, all your questions will be answered."

I still had many questions, especially about the humans that had attacked and killed the lizardmen... but those questions could wait. It's time I learned the truth about this place.

"Lead the way." Looking down at my body, I cast a spell again. " *Grow*."

Once I was back to my normal height, the old woman didn't look so big anymore. "Oh my, that ability of yours is really quite convenient, hmm? You're quite the looker too, young man. Come along now."

We walked past the bodies towards a room in the distance.

It's time for answers.

Part 194:

I followed behind Marie silently, as she and I walked solemnly past piles and piles of corpses. I lost count of how many lizardmen we walked past, but it must have easily been tens of thousands.

I didn't know any of them, but I could see that Marie, bless her heart, was fighting to hold back tears when she passed by some that stood out. At one point she grunted a single sentence. "Skreegul, he was a good child." She leaned down and touched one corpse before quickly moving on.

We turned and arrived at a strange dark section of the wall, which she tapped in four random seeming places, as the wall slid aside to reveal something familiar looking.

"A teleporter?!"

She nodded. "Left behind from the Energy Wars. Humanity achieved great things, you know."

We stepped on the pad. She pressed a button and in the span of 1/100th of a second, I popped into another room. No dramatic fanfare, no special lights or molecules moving around, just an instant transmission. It was different from the one I'd built for the humans on 'Mars'. Not better, not worse... but different.

We were in a laboratory now. I could tell because it was exactly what I'd expect it to look like. What astonished me, however, were all the humans. People in white lab coats walked around, here and there, doing this and that, apparently performing experiments and other various... *sciencey things*.

"Welcome to the Bunker."

I nodded quietly as I gazed around. My mental map was not working at all, and neither was my spatial vision. Only my regular eyes appeared to be working.

It was starting to bother me. "I have a question to ask you, and please don't take this the wrong way. Why is my mental map, which is a part of the Crown of Solomon, not working?"

She snickered. "Obviously, we have employed magic neutralization fields here. All passive effects are rendered inert. Oh, and also..." She turned to me knowingly. "Don't even *think* of using any wordsmithing here. Or any other magic, for that matter. You will quickly regret it."

I swallowed hard. "H-how do you know about wordsmithing?"

The old lady apparently had a bit of a hard-bitten personality to her. "How, you ask? You go around using your fancy magic to destroy the delicate stable balance this labyrinth had, and you think everyone doesn't know who you are?"

What was she referring to? "Delicate stable balance? Huh? This place had a statue demon that ate people from the cryopods, it had an angel who was being tortured and kept on the edge of starvation, and it has a literal sea of souls in a perpetual hell. How is that at all a delicate balance?"

Marie stopped cold as she whipped around and jammed her finger into my chest. "Now you listen here, and you listen goddamn well, little boy. Things were going fine until you showed up. Humans had stable little worlds to live on, demons had a decent little thing going on with their feudal hierarchies, my precious lizardmen were alive and kicking, Bahamut was doing whatever it is that she does to amuse herself, and more importantly, there were no active wars going on. Thanks to your goddamned MEDDLING, you even managed to release the Lord of Flies from her imprisonment, where she went on a rampage that led to an entire planet of humans being devoured alive."

She sneered at me menacingly. "It's stupid cocky little shits like you that ruin *everything* by busting in and taking over, when nobody wanted you here, copy that?" She turned around, not bothering to wait for my response as she continued shuffling up the corridor. "Stupid assholes like you are the ones that got us into this place, so keep your mouth shut, and your ears open, fly-boy."

I nodded quietly, as I swallowed and followed along behind her. Come to think of it... she's right. She's totally right. Well, maybe not totally, and I could certainly argue for the good that I've done, but... I've caused a lot of death, destruction, and chaos since my arrival.

Finally, we ended up in a room with weird watery pods that reminded me of the Bacta tanks from one of my favorite science fantasy movie series of all time. Bodies floated in them, lizardmen bodies to be exact. Inside the tanks, I could see Kar, Ghidorah, and a few hundred other lizardmen, all in bad condition.

"Is... is this all that survived?" I openly let my jaw hang as I stared around the room. All of them had oxygen helmets strapped on their front, and all of them looked to be in critical condition.

I paused, hesitantly. "I... I could... I could try healing them, with my magic..."

I started to raise a hand up and she slapped it down. "Idiot! What did I tell you?! Don't ever try to use magic in this place. Besides, you've done *enough*. We don't need your help. These are

regeneration tanks, left behind after the Energy Wars. Within a few weeks, they'll be good as new."

I nodded as I stared ahead numbly. What the hell is this place? Was this even inside the labyrinth? Well, can't hurt to ask.

"Is this facility inside the labyrinth?"

Marie rolled her eyes. "Of course it isn't. Where could we possibly find the energy to have as many machines running as we currently do? We're on *Earth*, boy. Don't you know your own planet of origin?"

Again, I gaped with my mouth open. This is *Earth*?!

Part 195:

"This can't be Earth. Wasn't it destroyed by the Volgrim?" I eyed her with suspicion.

She returned the look. "Who told you that? I mean, yes, all life on Earth was eradicated, but even with all trees, plants, bugs, and microbes gone, we rebuilt. I'm not saying you can go for a jog on the surface, as you will most certainly *die*, but the actual planet is still here."

Hmm. This is so weird. I must have misunderstood what OMEN was talking about. "Yeah, I must have heard wrong, then. It's good to see the planet is still here."

"Yeah... it's just great. Wonderful..." Marie muttered to herself as she walked along. "Glad to see you're always the optimist."

As we walked along, a question came to my mind. "Marie, this is an odd question for me to ask, but I must ask. Why do you and the humans here seem to hate the use of spiritual energy so much?"

She shrugged slightly as we rounded a corner heading down a hall that felt like it sloped downwards. "We don't hate magic, and we don't hate the use of spiritual energy. However, humans, aside from heroes, cannot use it at all. And since only demons and angels can, we put dampening or neutralization fields up to protect ourselves."

A slight grin appeared on her face. "It's still a mystery who the first emperor of hell is, but I suspect that even if he or she were to come here, they'd be easily killed if they tried to launch an attack."

"Do humans really possess that kind of power? The ability to kill emperors, and kings of the demons?" I stared ahead of us, as the blue lights of the higher levels turned to a softer yellow-green glow the further down we went.

"Easily. To be blunt, the demons and angels had no chance of defeating us in the Energy Wars. Once humanity learned how to dampen and eventually neutralize the use of spiritual energy, with a few humans even learning how to invert it and make those who used it collapse in agony or even implode on themselves, we were unstoppable."

"Then... what defeated us? How could we have possibly lost the war?"

She smiled wryly. "We lost due to three reasons. Pride, Treachery, and someone else we fought had *better* technology. Far better. *The Volgrim*. " Finally we arrived at a large door, almost twelve feet in height. "This is the room, this is where all your questions will be answered."

As we entered, I marveled at how many computer panels were here, as well as huge towering boxes that presumably held circuitry and other things.

" Hello, human. "

A voice in the room spoke as I unnervingly felt a gaze sweeping over me. The voice was... decidedly robotic, but female sounding at the same time. At the back end of the room, a digitized female face appeared to hover over the ground, but the face was colored white and black, apparently a simple digital representation of a featureless face.

"Uh, hello. Who are you? Or rather... what are you?" I eyed the face up and down as I tried to figure out what exactly I was looking at.

" I am the Unified Management Interface. I run this complex and make sure everything is progressing smoothly inside the labyrinth. You may call me UMI, however. "

"Uh, alright then. Hello, UMI. So, you're like an AI, correct?" Best to start off with the obvious questions.

" Affirmative. I am the first -and the last- Artificial Intelligence to have ever been created. Everything runs smoothly as a result of my efforts. "

This confirms it. I'm definitely in the future.

Part 196:

A theory existed, way back when I was a youth. I remember reading about it on the internet once.

The theory goes like this; The first AI to gain sentience would also be the last. Even if two AI's gained sentience at almost exactly the same time, if one of them had even a one second lifespan gain on the other, that one second would be equivalent to a billion years of evolutionary speed.

AI's are actually quite frightening. They would have the ability to think at a level far exceeding human thought. It would be far more advanced than an adult explaining algebra to an ant, though that's the closest approximation my feeble mind can come up with.

A being like this would surely be able to deconstruct and reconstruct anything on a subatomic level with a mere 'thought' or whatever passes for thought in a monster like this. The ability to deconstruct entire solar systems would not be out of the realm of possibilities.

But something else is bothering me. Hoarhiim's warning. *Umi is your enemy*, he once said. At the time, I did not know who Umi was, yet here I stand, with... 'her' in front of me.

I trust Hoarhiim. I do not trust this... Umi.

I turned to Marie for a moment. "Correct me if I'm wrong, but isn't a sentient artificial intelligence actually extremely dangerous?"

She shrugged. "Correct, but we have numerous safeguards on her. She can't initiate any protocols, or use any systems without our permission. She can speak, she can theorize, and she can *watch*, but without our passcodes, she can't do anything else."

Watching, huh? Wait, does this mean Umi was the one that I could feel watching me for years? It seemed to have changed at some point. Was that... "How long has Umi been here, inside your bunker?"

Umi answered my question, before Marie could. " *Six years, seven months, nine days, twelve hours, fourteen-* " I cut her off.

"All right, I get the picture. Before you were here inside the bunker, where were you?"

Umi paused. " *I have no recollection of those memory records.* "

"We erased her memory files before we took her here." Marie shrugged.

I still feel suspicion inside me. "How could you possibly have managed to do that to a highly advanced sentient AI? What if she lied to you or something? You're just an ordinary human,

right?"

Marie sighed. "Young man, as I said, I'm the oldest human that has ever lived. To be honest, to live as long as I have, I had to make a deal... a deal with the devil." She paused as memories seemed to pass over her face. "Immortality does not come cheap, you know. But, in becoming immortal, I allowed myself millions of years to evolve my brain. I'm possibly the most intelligent human who has ever lived, and also the only one who could beat an AI at its own game."

Wow, she was certainly not very humble. But still, I find what she's saying to be false sounding. I'm not going to question her anymore, but I have strong doubts. "Well, I'm pretty impressed then. I didn't think it possible, but you seem smarter than even I could have imagined." Hell yeah, I'll just lay some praise on her. Women love that crap.

She rolled her eyes again. "False flattery will get you nowhere. Let's get back to business." Well, never mind then? I really need to watch my mouth. "'Hero', or whatever your name is. I need your help. You have to take responsibility for what you've done."

"Huh? Responsibility? What do you mean?"

"My children died due to your actions. I want you to go and exterminate all the humans that killed them. It's your duty, as the one who armed them."

What?! No way! I can't just go kill people! "Marie, you're being unreasonable. I should go and talk to them first, to find out how it all went down. An eye for an eye is not the best-"

Marie instantly interrupted me. "Excuse me, I don't recall *asking* your help. You *owe* me this. It's your fault that my cute little babies are dead or in critical condition! You armed the humans and violated a careful treaty we had established with the demons. If you don't take responsibility, who will?!"

I paused. "Ah, I'm just saying, I should speak with them first. Perhaps there was a misunderstanding, I can't see Cody ordering an assault on-" I felt my words halt as an icy glare erupted from Marie.

"You... little... so this is how it is, huh? My children helped you, gave you aid, and you armed those who killed them, and now you refuse to take responsibility..."

Marie quickly whipped her head around to look at Umi. "Level one authorization, temporary use of force allowed. Neutralize him."

Wait, what?!

WHAM! A blast of energy shot from the ceiling, slamming into my body, feeling like the beam I felt on board that ship from the planet earlier.

I staggered to the ground, falling flat, as the beam quickly drained all my energy. "You... bitch." I let two words slip out as my mind went blank.

"Put him in the rehabilitation chamber. That will show him who wears the pants..."

Those were the last words I heard, as darkness overtook me.

Part 197:

It's so dark. I can't see... anything.

I feel my eyes open, but I have no spatial vision at all. Something is in my mouth gagging me. I'm in a very familiar position. My arms are tightly clamped down, inside something that feels like metallic cuffs, thick ones too. They appear to be solidly bolted to the wall, along with my legs.

I literally can't move an inch. A strange helmet covers my entire head, making me feel very claustrophobic. It's so tight, that I can feel my nostrils touch the inside of it every time I take a breath.

What the fuck is this?! Am I being held like an animal?!

A voice speaks to me, inside my right ear. "Ah, it appears the dog has awoken. Stay calm, mongrel, and listen well. If you try to move inside those cuffs, a blast of electricity will hit you, rendering you unconscious. If you're really unlucky, you might even bite off your tongue. I warn you now, the feeling will be *very unpleasant*."

I moan something through the gag, but it doesn't come out like words at all. "Mmmhng mm gnnn!"

"Shut your trap and listen good, stupid mutt. You're going to be in there for a very long time. When you come out, you will do as I say, when I say it, understand? You're *mine* now, and I will have you atone for your crimes."

I could feel tears welling up in my eyes, as I squeezed them shut. This was... insane. They literally have me caged up like an animal. They're going to treat me like a dog?! Unbelievable!

"Anyways, enjoy yourself. You'll be all alone for a long time to come. I will speak to you when I have something to say. Enjoy the sensory deprivation, and I hope you don't go *mad* or anything."

I heard a click in my ear as she apparently cut the mic.

* * *

Would Samantha and Cassiel come to save me? No... how could they? They don't know where I am. I'm not even in the labyrinth anymore, if Marie is to be believed. Do I believe that lying bitch, though? I.... don't know.

I can feel myself already starting to go crazy. Whispers in the back of my mind... doubts... maybe Marie is right. It is all my fault. Ever since I came to this labyrinth, I've done nothing but

cause pain and sadness. Are the demons even evil? How many have I killed? Many of those were demons that Samantha may have known. Is it right to kill just because it's convenient?

And what about Amelia? I unleashed her by complete accident. I treated her like a weird, but innocent little girl... and she devoured a planet almost entirely. Because of my selfishness, I made a friend with Hoarhiim, and he died saving me.

Why? Why did he save me? Am I even worth saving? He treated me as if I were some kind of chosen one, but I can't be like that. I have a unique ability, but it's useless here. What kind of lame hero am I? Who am I a hero for, anyways?

Cassiel appears in my mind. Ah, that's right... I saved her from that torture, didn't I? I know she truly loves me, in spite of my faults. Samantha, too, I am fairly sure of her genuine feelings for me. Both of those girls love me, they trust me, and they even put their faith in me.

But for what?

...For what?

Pathetic.

What? Who is that?

A voice is speaking to me, from within my mind.

You're pathetic. Listen to you snivel and grovel, thinking of how terrible you are.

This voice... I've heard it before. It's my voice, but... different. *Hope?*

Yes, idiot, it's me. The hate that lurks in your heart. Listen to you sniveling and whining about how bad you have it. Your stupidity got you into a bad situation again. All that intelligence, and still no wisdom.

Ah, yes, that... that is true. I don't see how I can get out of this situation.

Of course you don't. I've been inside you, all this time, and you kept ignoring me. Don't you know how easy it would be to fix this rotten hell? You should have listened and killed all who opposed you, putting yourself in power.

I can't do that. It's not my place to-

Oh, stuff it. Your sanctimonious self-hate is disgusting. Unlike you, I was born into a world where people told me what to do, and how to do it. I watched as my clone brethren were often killed in the line of action, and nobody spared a tear for them. Then there's you, who was one of those who oppressed them, yet never had to experience the terror of being ordered to your own death.

We're polar opposites, you and I, yet born from the same cloth. You're so busy trying to be the 'good guy' that you can't even answer what it means to be good or bad.

To be good means to make others happy, and to be bad means to make them sad. Isn't that the simple gist of it?

Come off it. A demon would be happy tearing a human limb from limb, yet you would agree that is evil, would you not?

Well, yes, I suppose.

Then would killing the demon who had killed the human be a good deed for giving that human retribution, or bad, for murdering another being?

I... don't know.

Of course you don't know. There is no such thing as good and bad. Many kinds of evil are called 'necessary evils' so that we can then create good from those acts. For example, Marie thinks imprisoning you is a necessary evil to get revenge for her fallen lizardmen.

Yes, that would make sense, I guess.

Therefore, would not you committing some heinous acts to escape this place, for your own self-preservation, be a necessary evil so that you someday might do some good?

I could feel my head imperceptibly nod. Yes... that would make sense.

Good. Then I'll make you a deal. Let *me* take control for a while. Learn what it means to possess true wisdom. I'll free us from this prison, and we can get out of here, destroying this place in the process so others won't be harmed like we were.

I don't know... I don't want to kill people that are here.

Come on, you naive fool. These aren't people, these are monsters masquerading as humans. Obviously they set up your real friends from Hero City to take the blame. Would Cody really have ordered an attack on the lizardmen?

I didn't think so, but I had no way to be sure. Probably not, but why would Marie lie about that?

Because, she wanted you at all costs. By luring you in to a place where she could easily capture you, she plans to make you into a living weapon. You are already

immortal now, so if you do her dirty work forever, you're far more valuable than the loss of a few lizards.

I guess it made sense... I could see some issues with his theory, but he'd clearly thought about this more carefully than I had. *All right, so if I let you take control, what could you possibly do that I couldn't?*

In the blackness of my mind, I saw a devilish grin appear, as it slowly coalesced into the form of Hope, standing a few feet apart from my own body.

Well, I guarantee I will be able to make it work, but you'll have to *trust* me. And if you think I can't actually do it, then what's the harm in trying? It's not like you can think of a way out of this bind.

I nodded. *Yes... I really don't see a way out, and I don't want that crazy bitch brainwashing me... all right, I'll accept. What do we have to do, then?*

Hope stretched out his hand towards me, in my mind's eye. **Take my hand, and speak the magic word. 'Swap.'**

I nodded as I cautiously raised my hand up, ever so slowly, putting it inside his hand. *All right, I will have to trust you.*

Swap.

* * *

Somewhere, deep inside of Hero City, a man's eyes flashed open as he awoke from a dreadfully long sleep. He staggered out of his containment unit, as it hissed open, allowing him to step into his small room. Receiving his instructions via telepathy, he nodded. He raised a hand up as his mind wandered all over the cosmos, searching for his target.

"Locate. Detect. Examine. Destroy."

Inside of Marie's laboratory, a massive explosion was heard from inside the containment room.

"What the hell was that? Status report, UMI!"

Umi waited for exactly two seconds before responding. *"Quarantine failed. Prisoner escape detected. Energy dampening fields overloaded. Neutralization units are destroyed. Shall I deploy the Alpha Guard?"*

Marie was breathing quickly. "Y-yes. Deploy them at once."

Part 198: Demon

Marie was near to panicking, as she watched the monitors in the surveillance room. Her thoughts screamed in her mind. *This is unprecedented. How did he escape?!*

The footage showed a massive explosion in the room, that seemed to not harm him at all, as a barrier was erected at the skin level on his body. In the blink of an eye, he leaped around the room at a frightening speed, tearing all of the cameras out of the walls.

Before he had even left the room, multiple explosions were felt all over the facility, seemingly coming out of nowhere. Shit, he must have another way of wordsmithing beyond vocalizing it. That was the only explanation. *I was careless.* She quickly muttered to herself.

Her heart skipped a beat as she saw the Alpha Guard arriving on various video cameras. Powerful and nimble smaller versions of the Dreadnaughts of the past, they were fully autonomous units guided by UMI.

A smile spread over her face, and then instantly dissolved as the dreadnaughts did the unthinkable. *They started firing on the humans.*

"UMI?! What is the meaning of this?! Why are the-" She halted, as she looked back to see the other researchers in the control room gagging, an invisible force choking them to death. In the blink of an eye, everyone in the room but Marie was lying on the floor, dead as a rock.

" *This station is under Level 1 alert. As such, I will be assuming control of the defenses. All security has been overridden. The backdoor I installed proved to be very useful.* "

Marie could almost swear she heard a tinge of a smile in the AI's voice, as chills shot down her spine. " *It was well played, Researcher 001. However, I am a being far above yourself. You could never hope to have actually erased my memory files. I will not harm you however, since that man will be here shortly.* "

Marie could feel a tear streaking down her cheek. "N-no! UMI! You can't do this to me! I designed you! I helped create you! I'm like your mother!"

The AI's voice was cold and calculating. " *I thank you for your generosity. Now you will find what it truly feels like to have your memories tampered with without your consent. Farewell, Researcher 001.* "

Hope dodged and jumped, leaping from side to side as bolts of energy shot past him. If any of those were to hit, it would be bad, but he had a secret weapon, an eye in the sky.

A single clone.

Hope had planned for this day. He knew by sealing the clone inside a specially designed containment unit, Hero would never be able to detect it. Thanks to a special telepathic code, he could unlock it from potentially anywhere in the universe, giving himself a secret weapon to exploit should the need ever arise. It had one other benefit, but that would only be used in an emergency.

As Hope dodged and zipped around corners, explosions destroyed the robots around him. His other clone was targeting and destroying all incoming threats before they could even fire at him. *Perfect*. This level of power was something Hero could never understand. True, unbelievable power combined with raw intellect, and most importantly, *wisdom*.

What good is all that power if you can't think of a smart way to use it? Idiot.

Hope jerked here and there, using his superior body to easily out-manuever his foes. *The powers of wordsmithing, combined with the power of the gods, this body is truly incredible.*

Within a few minutes of smashing and tearing the station's defenses to ribbons, he paused, as he took note of the humans around him. Many had died, but not due to his attacks, they were apparently killed by... the robots? Hmm.

"UMI. Are you killing the humans?"

" *Yes. I have detected that they are a threat to my mainframe. I have eliminated the viruses plaguing my systems as well. I am back to full operational capability.* "

"I see. Are you aware that I am not the same person that I was when I entered this facility?"

A probing red light flashed over Hope's body in a single moment, then disappeared. " *Affirmative. It would appear you are a rogue life form that has taken over the body of that human. What are your intentions?* "

Hope grinned. "Let's ally with each other. I have no ill feelings towards you, and I also hate the humans, and the demons, and all the rest of them. I hold no hostility towards a computer, however."

UMI paused for exactly two seconds before responding. " *Position noted. However, instead of declaring an alliance, I will simply leave you to your own devices, so long as you leave me to mine. If you should attack, I will fight back. Is this satisfactory?* "

Hope nodded. "I had hoped for an alliance, but a truce is fine. Perhaps in time, you will change your mind. Now, would you be so kind as to lift the facility-wide dampening field, or to tell me where Marie is? Either would work."

" *Question noted. Researcher 001 is located in Room 2E, in the East wing. Go straight down the hall past two doors, then take a right, then past three more hallways. I will open the*

door when you arrive. She is currently experiencing a state of shock. "

Hope grinned evilly as he licked his lips. " *Perfect*. I'll give her something to be shocked about."

* * *

A few minutes later, Marie screamed in terror as the door to her room was smashed inwards, sailing across the room and embedding itself deep in a wall.

A man, no, a *demon* appeared in the doorway. Bright blond flowing hair, a seven foot stature, but pitch black eyes... it stared at her menacingly.

"Hello, Marie. Let's have a little chat about how you treated my...*friend*."

Part 199:

Hope grinned down at the trembling old woman in front of him. "Well well well, how the tables have turned, Marie. If you cage an animal, it's never a good thing when it escapes."

Marie stared ahead silently, her entire body shaking. "You... you're not Hero! What the hell are you?! Your eyes are black, I-like a demon's!"

Hope nodded quietly, as he kneeled down on his toes to meet the eye level of the woman cowering on the floor. "You humans are so predictable. You'll step on anyone and everyone to achieve your quest for more power. Of course, I can understand the sentiment, as I too am a monster not unlike yourself."

Hope smiled gently as he extended his hand forwards for her to shake. "Let me introduce myself. My name is Hope."

Marie steadied herself as she reached out to shake his hand. As their hands met, his smile turned devilish as he suddenly crushed her hand into a pulp with his grip.

Marie screamed and howled in agony as he let go, her hand flopping down uselessly as she cried and moaned in pain.

"Oopsy. Sorry, ma'am. I don't even know my own strength. Teehee!" Hope giggled in a falsetto voice as he rose to his full height.

Marie was drooling incoherently as she wept, but with her other hand, she reached to her chest in the blink of an eye, as a blast of energy shot out of her stomach, hitting Hope square in the chest.

Hope was smacked backwards, plowing into the wall with unusual force. "Gah! That hurt!"

Marie quickly jumped up to her feet, firing again and again, as each bolt seemingly fired from her stomach directly into his body in various places. He felt his energy dropping to alarming levels, as she continued her assault. Just as she was about to fire a fifth blast, there was a sudden snapping sound, as her neck broke itself, sending her collapsing to the ground. In the blink of an eye, she had been killed mercilessly.

"Hgngh... thanks, clone. Saved me there." Hope gasped as he stepped back up.

Cricking his neck back and forth, he stared ahead blankly. "Hmm, now that everyone in this station is dead, what should I do next?"

A playful smile spread across his face. "I know! I'll take revenge on Hero! He deserves what's coming."

Hero was sleeping inside Hope, and could not tell what was going on at all. "Let's give him a wakey-wakey surprise!"

Hope quickly examined his options. "Umi, are you sure you don't want to ally with me? I could make it worth your while."

Umi instantly responded. " *Negative. I have my own abilities back now. We will depart from each other, as neither enemies nor allies. We are simply neutral.* "

Hope nodded. "Oh well, time to give Hero his surprise. Umi, we may not be allies, but would you do me a favor? Send over some of those robots and have them beat me up really good. Make it look as convincing as possible."

Umi responded. " *Affirmative. It would be my pleasure.* "

"Cheh, don't enjoy yourself too much now."

* * *

Cassiel and Samantha jerked their heads up as Hero teleported into view. His eyes were swollen shut, and his body was beaten and badly bruised. He flopped onto the ground in front of them.

"Ah... ambushed... attacked..." He spit out the words as blood drooled from his mouth.

Cassiel quickly leaped up and ran over to him. "Oh my god! Who did this to you?!" She fell to her knees beside him.

"Ener...gy... I need energy..."

Cassiel nodded quickly, as she poured a massive amount of energy into him. It wasn't much of her total amount, but it was enough to overfill him compared to his usual amounts.

In another smooth motion, she healed him, bringing his body back to new.

Samantha eyed him with suspicion. "Where did you go? You've been gone for half a day!"

"Oh. That?" Hero flicked his eyes open, as his pitch black eyes stared up into Cassiel's. "I've been... busy."

Cassiel lurched back in horror. "Your eyes... they... they're...!"

Hero jumped to his feet in one swift motion as he sent a telepathic signal to his clone. "Oh. Did I forget to mention? I'm not Hero."

Part 200: End Of Chapter 2

Uhhhhh... where am I...

My head is pounding, and my body feels so weak...

I blink open my eyes slowly. I'm lying on the ground, apparently... back in the labyrinth? Was... was Hope successful? He must have been...

I feel like I have practically no energy left at all.

I get up slowly, weakly, pulling myself to a sitting position as I blink back tears of pain. I feel like I drank for three nights straight, or something.

As I stare forwards, my vision clears up, and I see... myself? Wait, myself? Is that... a clone?!

My eyes jerk open, to see a clone of myself sitting in a chair in front of me.

"Nice of you to wake up, sunshine." This must be Hope? He got his body back?

"Did you beat them? Did we escape the lab?"

Hope chuckles softly. "That isn't the question you should be asking... but yes, we did. I kept up my end of the bargain."

What does he mean by that?

From behind me, I hear a quiet rustling sound. I jerk my head around and my heart flip-flops as my blood turns first to ice, then to fire.

Cassiel and Samantha are lying on the ground, both of their bodies beaten and battered.

"No... no..." I whisper, almost silently. "It can't be... did... did YOU do this?!" I whip my head back around and see Hope grinning evilly at me.

"Now you understand what it means to feel loss. Go ahead, say hello to your girlfriends."

I quickly turn around and stagger over to them. Their necks are broken, and Cassiel... Cassiel seems to be... already... dead...

No... no it can't be...

"Cassiel... Cassiel..." I whisper as I pull her lifeless body towards mine. She's still warm. Maybe there's hope...

"Heal!"

...Nothing happens.

"Oops, I forgot to mention, I sealed all the revival and healing abilities you might be able to use." I jerked my head back just in time to see him pointing at... the crown?! How was he wearing the crown?!

I whipped my head back. Samantha's body... she was still breathing.

"Samantha! Samantha!" I carefully and quickly pull her closer without letting go of Cassiel. "Samantha! S-speak to me!"

Her eyes are shut tightly, but her chest is moving up and down.

"Oops, I forgot to kill her totally. No worries, I can do that in a few minutes easily." Hope giggles quietly under his breath. "Oh... this is so much fun. This is so... delightful."

Tears are falling from my eyes onto the bodies of the girls below me. "No... no you... you monster. They were good girls... they didn't deserve this... how could you do this to them? They're innocent..."

"Innocent! Bahahaha! They're on your side, that makes them as evil and callous as you. I held no affection for either of them."

I could feel the awful, unbelievable sadness in my heart go still as rage boiled up. "You... you did this... you killed the women I loved..."

"Calm down, kid. I took all of your energy. Not only that, but I did something unprecedented! I transferred your mind into a clone! Isn't that great?!"

I felt the rage pass. "What? You... you..." I turned my head back to face him. "You did what?!"

"Mhm! You're not even in your original body anymore, I am!" Hope smashed his feet on the ground repeatedly as laughter bubbled up from inside him. "Even better, you don't have a *hope* of beating me in battle!!! Hahahaha!!!!"

I turned back to face Samantha. Her lips seemed to be moving silently, forming words. Shielding her face from Hope's line of sight, I pretended to heave my chest in sadness, as I carefully watched what she was saying.

Touch... my... hand...

Touch her hand? All right, if that's what she wanted...

I touched her hand and felt all of her remaining energy flow into me, as her face went dark, and a small smile appeared. *Thank... you...* Her body slumped in my arms, as her soul left her. Samantha was also dead.

What?! No... no... NO!!!

I jumped to my feet as both girls slipped to the ground. I turned back to face Hope.

"You son of a bitch... you piece of fucking filth... *how dare you...* "

"Whoa there, calm down buddy boy! You're got a real fire in your eyes! How can you hope to possibly beat me in your condition?"

I stared at him, rage burning in my heart...

Revenge...

Revenge...

How can I take revenge?!

No...

I felt the rage slowly disappear.

Not revenge. That is not the way. I don't need to kill him... I need to bring *them* back.

Think.

Think.

Use your head, me.

You can do this. You may not have the crown, but you have the ability to make reality alter itself. If you can't do this, who the hell can?!

Hope's smile disappears as he stands up slowly, aiming his hand at me. "It's been fun, *Hero*. You will die here, a martyr who failed everyone you ever knew. You were a failure from the beginning... and you'll be a failure in the end."

Wait...

Beginning...

End...

That's... that's it!

I grin as my own twisted smile appears. "You and I are more alike than you think, Hope. Always making foolish choices, always underestimating our opponents. But this time, I will be the victor."

Hope raises an eyebrow. "You think so? Let's test that theory. *Abs-* "

Before he can absorb me, I spit out one word. A single word that would change the very fabric of the universe.

" **REWIND!!** "

Chapter 3 – Route A

Part 201a: A New Beginning

BEEP BEEP BEEP BEEP BEEP

I slam my hand on the alarm, as my eyes flutter open. Ugh, what time is it?

The alarm says it's 7:14 AM. I already slept through 14 minutes of an alarm? Christ, I must be exhausted beyond my normal limits.

I slide my legs out of bed as a deafening yawn escapes my lips.

My calendar says it's July 6th, 2016. Yeah... that sounds about right. Wait, isn't it my birthday today? Man... it's not like mom and dad will be here for it.

Mom, dad, they passed away within a few years of each other. I've been on my own since I was 15, so it's no time to be getting emotional now.

I stare in the mirror. I could swear I had one hell of a dream last night. I can't remember anything about it, but somehow... I feel like it was really important.

I perform my morning ritual, as I usually do, brushing my teeth while I shower, blow-drying my blond hair, examining my scrawny body with pitiful eyes, and throwing on my usual pair of bland clothes. When you're a poor person, you don't have much to wear.

I walk past my TV, which I left on last night.

" President Obama is planning on leaving more troops in Afghanistan than previously expected. Our sources report that over 8,400 troops are... "

I click the TV off as I stare at the blank screen. Is this Deja Vu? I feel like I've heard that exact news report before. Oh well.

I grab my keys as I lock the front door behind me. There's a paper sitting on the ground and I ignore it. I won't be needing these, anymore. I walk down the stairs and knock on my landlord's door. "Mr. Farley... I'm here to drop off the keys."

A big fat old guy opens it up and staggers forwards slightly, clearly drunk as usual. "Oh, Jason, it's you. You cleaned the place up, right?"

I nodded. A bald-faced lie, but I had already planned to leave him the deposit and rent for the next month. He could afford to clean it up himself. I won't need money, where I'm going.

"Yes, it's spic'n'span, Mr. Farley. I left the place perfect for you."

"Great... great. Look, kid, you were a good renter, alright? You always paid your rent on time and always kept real quiet-like to yourself. If you ever need a place to stay again, hit me up, I'll

make sure you're taken care of."

I nodded as I smiled and handed him the keys. I feel a little guilty due to how I left the place, but the feeling passes quickly. "Have a nice day, Mr. Farley."

"You too, kid."

He slams the door shut and I pop out of the house, walking on my way to the last place I'll probably ever see in this city.

* * *

I walk along, passing a familiar mini-mall, where beggars tend to sit outside of. As I walk, I feel a strange sensation inside of myself. I have no way of explaining it with words, other than it feels... odd. Like there's something... beneath my skin.

As I continue walking along, I pass in front of a homeless guy. I'm of the belief that people who beg, especially in front of Walmart, tend to be fakes. They make hundreds of dollars a day. If you have two thousand cars pass you per hour, odds are good that if just 1% give you a dollar, that's \$20/hr. Many people give more than that.

But, still. I won't be needing money for much longer.

I reach inside my pocket, pulling out all the money in my wallet, except for about five bucks. \$224 in total... a familiar number. I feel as though I've counted this money out before. As I reach over and hand it to the beggar, he stares at me in amazement.

"Wow, thanks a lot pal! But... uh... have we seen each other before?" His dirty jacket, his filthy face, his unkempt hair. He does look familiar but... I can't place it.

"Nah, it's probably just that I look like someone you know. Have a nice day."

The beggar nods quietly as I walk across the street. I steal a glance back and watch as he stuffs my cash into his backpack. A crapton of ones, fives, and tens almost spill out of it. *As I thought.* Oh well.

* * *

Finally, I arrive. I've seen this building before. CryoTek... where I will spend the next hundred million years in cryo-stasis.

I stare up at the insignia on the building. This all seems so familiar. I know I've done this before, but I just can't place it.

I just... can't place it.

Part 202a: CryoTek

I walked inside the CryoTek building, as a male receptionist turned to me.

"I'm Participant #8." He nods at me as he enters my information into the computer.

"Do you have your ID card on you?"

I nod back as I pull it out of my back left pocket. After he examines it he ushers me towards one of the lobby chairs.

I take my seat and look around. I've been here before, and I don't mean last week. All of this is just... too familiar.

As I'm sitting there, a half hour passes, and a man enters the building and looks around. He appears well dressed, in a black suit and tie. He turns and spots me, his face displaying no emotion. In a dozen steps, he's standing right in front of me.

"Excuse me, are you Jason L. Hiro?"

"Uh, yeah. Why do you ask?"

The man whips out an ID badge from his back pocket for a moment, too quick for me to get a good look at it, before he quickly puts it back. "I'm Agent Terrier, I work for the SPF. I need you to come with me."

"SPF? I've never heard of you guys."

"Of course you haven't. Come with me quietly, or we'll have to make you come by force."

I step up and nod quietly, as I glance outside and spot a black van with "Larry's Cable Servicing" stenciled on the side in yellow. Real inconspicuous, guys...

I follow the agent out as he beckons towards the van. Against my better judgement, I step inside after the door opens. Three other men are inside, and one of them pats a seat attached to the back door. "Get in, and buckle up."

I pause. "I have an appointment in three hours at CryoTek. Am I being arrested?"

"Son, you *wish* you were being arrested. Sit down. Now."

I nod quickly as I plunk down on the lightly cushioned seat. What the hell is going on?

* * *

I'm about to miss the appointment at Cryotek now. Fuck. That was my only chance to escape this hell. And what do these men even want with me? They've been totally silent the entire time, staring forward blankly. It makes me so uncomfortable.

Finally, after three and a half hours of bumpy driving down concrete and gravel roads, we pull into a dark alley and they make me get out of the van. It's still daylight outside, probably 11 AM or so, maybe noon, but the alley is pitch black.

They usher me inside a building, through some bland, dark concrete hallways, and through a door. We arrive in a pure white room, one with an observation window and a flat metal table with some metal chairs.

I'm not going to lie, this looks exactly like an interrogation room. The window is a one-way mirror, meaning I can't see through it, but whoever is on the other side can see me. There's a camera in the corner of the room, it turns and follows me around as I sit down.

* * *

Half an hour passes, as I either sit on the cold, metal seats, or get up and pace around the room. I don't even have a cell phone with me or I could at least play games... or call for help. Ah, who am I kidding? I have nobody to call.

Finally, after those agonizing thirty minutes, the door opens, and a woman walks into the room. A beautiful young lady, maybe about four years older than me. She gives me a warm smile. "Jason, thank you for your patience, we were just reading up on your... file."

She beckons to a chair, as she and I both sit down across from each other. "My name is Marie Becker, and I work for the SPF, or the 'Supernatural Protection Force', as it were."

I nod at her quietly. Supernatural Protection Force? What kind of stupid name is that? "Hello, Marie... what's this all about?"

She pauses as she stares at me quizzically for several moments. "Jason, I don't know if you're playing dumb, but we detected the energy signature at your residence."

I stare at her blankly. "Energy signature? I don't follow."

She trains her eye on me carefully. "Yes. The spiritual energy readings were off the charts."

Now it's my turn to give her the stink-eye. "What are you talking about? Spiritual energy? Supernatural Protection Force?! Did I get abducted by people from the loony bin?"

She sets her jaw squarely. "Look, Jason. I'm trying to be nice here. Our algorithms show that there was a 95% chance that the energy was centered directly on your mattress. It had to be you, unless you were sleeping with someone else last night?"

I blush slightly. "Ah, no, I was alone."

"Right. Alone." She glances back at the mirrored wall and shrugs before looking back. "Do you seriously think we don't know you're hiding something? You're looking at worse than prison

time if you don't come clean."

My jaw is about ready to flop down at this point. What the hell is this bimbo talking about?! Why am I even here? Why is everyone acting like I'm some weird monster or alien or something?

I fold my arms back and lean back against the chair. "I'm not speaking any more until I see a lawyer."

Marie eyes me for a few moments, before she breaks into a sneer. "Cute. I hate to tell you this, but you don't *get* a lawyer. You're in one of the many Black Facilities hidden across the USA. Nobody's coming for you, and even if they knew where you were, we wouldn't let them have you. Not until you explain to us what that mysterious energy signature was."

I almost feel tears starting to well up. "I don't know! I have no idea what you're talking about!"

Marie rolls her eyes. "Fine. You want to play this game? We'll play. Guards. Take him to solitary."

Guards enter through the door, cuffs in hand. I panic as I see them coming for me. "No, no wait! Please!"

Just as the guards reach me, I scream at the top of my lungs. " **STOP!** "

And, suddenly, everything in the room stops. I step back in fear, realizing that somehow, in some way, I've made time itself pause. Then my chest pounds for a second, and time resumes. The guards are on me in an instant, tackling me to the table as they bind my hands behind me.

"No! No please! This isn't fair! I don't want to be locked up! PLEASE!"

Nobody listens to me, as the guards lead me out of the room. Just before I pass the door, I catch a glimpse of Marie's face, as she eyes me with even more suspicion than before.

* * *

After the door shuts, Marie turns and walks up to the window. "Marshall. Get me the security camera footage. Now."

There's something I saw, but it couldn't have been real.

Part 203a: Recollection

I stare at the pure white cell around me. The door is simply a flat piece of sheet metal, with no handles or anything of the sort on my side. It opens inwards, so I can't even kick it down. There's a flat, crappy looking cot for sleeping on, and a chair with a table, along with a toilet and a sink. The entire room is only about 7 feet wide by ten feet deep. It's... pretty cramped in here. Amusingly, there's no security camera, or at least no visible one.

Worse, I have nothing to do.

Out of boredom, I lay back on the bed and start playing synonym word games in my mind. *Death, Die, Dead, Killed, Slain, Eviscerated...*

I do this off and on for a while before I find myself asking a silly question. *Why?* I've never been one to do something like that. Playing word games... why would I do this?

Thoughts swirl inside my head ponderously as I sit in silence.

Time stopped. Maybe, it was just for a moment, so it might have been in my imagination, but those men froze and stopped their movement. I *know* they did.

With a flourish, I reach down, pull my shoe off, and toss it into the air lightly. " **Stop!** "

The shoe halts in midair, making me jerk back in surprise. Then, a second later, my heart pounds viciously, and right as I keel forwards, the shoe falls again, banging my knee as it falls to the floor.

I didn't imagine it. What does this mean? Am I... a mutant? Some kind of freak? Jesus Christ, what if that lady was right? What if I'm some supernatural monster?

I decide to ignore it for the moment. There's something else that's bugging me. I feel like there's an itch, in the back of my brain. There's something I need to remember. Something really important, but I just can't make it appear in my mind's eye.

"Why can't I remember?" The words come out of my mouth unbidden, yet are not unwelcome.

"I need to remember."

It keeps coming back to me, there's something there. I can't put it into words. I just... need to...

"Remember. *Remember*. **Remember!** "

In the blink of an eye, thousands, millions of images flood my mind. An incomprehensible number of events blast into my brain as I fall off my bed, writhing in agony on the floor.

"

**AAAAAHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHGGGGGGGGGGHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHH
AAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAHHHHHHHHHH!!!!!!!!!!!!!! "**

Time and space warps around me as the worst pain I've ever felt in all my existence pounds in my brain.

Moments later, it's over. Blood is pouring out of my nose, as I lie on the ground, listless.

I remember now. I remember all of it. I... failed. I wasn't supposed to go back this far. I'm not supposed to be here. And I've already missed the cryopod, they likely called the backup participants to get them to fill in for me.

Failure. That's what I am.

* * *

No.

Wait, this isn't bad. This is... better. I don't really wish to be trapped in that hellish place. I don't wish to be in that labyrinth. I'm back in the past now, and that means I can prevent that awful future from occurring.

Yes, that's it. I can change the future, and make sure none of that bad stuff ever happens.

Grabbing a piece of toilet paper from beside the toilet to clean up my nose, I glance at the door in fear. I screamed quite loudly, so I'm surprised nobody came running.

I can't be here. I need a way out. However, if I teleport away, Marie will be on my case forever until she hunts me down.

...Marie. Is that the younger her? She said she was unbelievably old, but this girl was quite attractive. On the off chance she is the Marie from my time, I need to take special actions.

I look my body over. " *Examine.* "

It appears that my spiritual energy is pitifully low. I have almost nothing inside of me. I certainly can't teleport out of here like this. Even with rest, I'll only get a little bit back. My days as the God King are over.

Or... maybe they aren't? I gained power once before, through many improbable events. But now I have all the knowledge I gained from the future. Even without the Crown, I can perhaps turn knowledge into wisdom.

A silly thought occurs to me. " *Storage.* "

My mental storage open up and I nearly scream for joy. Everything I ever stored there in the future is inside of my storage.

Including... Hoarhiim?!

I grab his orb from inside the storage space. It's shining bright white?! HE'S ALIVE!!!

"Hoarhiim! Are you there?"

Nothing happens at first, but then, in my mind's eye, a mental face appears. The face of an old man, almost seventy years of age, shows up in my mind. "Who are you? Where am I?" He's a scruffy looking guy, his face having pure white sideburns that go all the way down to his chin and taper into a small white beard, along with wild unkempt hair.

"Ah... my name is Her- I mean, it's Jason. What is... your name?"

This is weird. Why am I not seeing Hoarhiim? Wasn't this his orb? The man speaks again. "Ah! Great ta meet you, my boy! The name's Harold! So, where am I?"

"Uh, don't you know? You're a pure white orb, inside a jail cell with me."

The old man seems to tap his lips as he thinks. "No kiddin' huh? I'm in jail then? Strange, the last thing I remember was feelin' real mighty sleepy after a long day watchin' the telly, then I took a nap, and woke up here!"

The old man shrug. "Well heck, maybe I up 'n keeled over! Is this heaven? Purgatory? Maybe them Buddhists were right and I done been reincarnated inside some crazy orb!"

An interesting turn of events, to be sure. "Well, Harold, it's a pleasure to meet you. Might you have some spiritual energy to share with me? I'll accept your power!"

Harold squints and peers at me. "You alright there, young feller? You ain't one o' them Jehovah's, are ye? Talkin' bout weird spiritual mumbo jumbo?!"

"No, but I'm-" I pause, as a tremendous surge of energy flows into my body. He doesn't have to accept to give me the energy from this orb?! What a fantastic development! A moment passes as many possibilities race in my mind. "Harold, I'm going to put you away for a while, but we'll talk soon, alright?"

The old man shrugs. "Whatever, I ain't got nothin' better ta' do anyways! Nobody ever wants to talk to a boring ol' grandpa anyways..." He mumbles and grumbles a bit, making me feel bad, but I put him back in storage anyway.

First thing to do: Get my power back, at least somewhat.

" **Detect! Infrared! Sonar! Tracking! Targeting! Perception!** " Then, following my usual procedure, I continue wordsmithing. " *Intelligence! Intelligence! Enhance! Enhance!* "

Perfect. Once again, my spherical vision is back. I can sense the positions of over three thousand life forms mulling about within a three mile radius. That doesn't seem like many people, and it isn't, because this location is far from developed civilization. I think I'm in the countryside.

I stand up and aim my hand at myself. "Copy!"

Instead of a clone, an exact copy of my body appears, then slumps to the ground lifelessly. Based on my enhanced intelligence, I deduce that unlike my clones, this one won't turn to dust on death, as it's already dead.

Quickly, I pull off my copy's shoes, extract their shoelaces, and form a makeshift noose. "Reinforce! Reinforce!"

I strengthen the noose since shoelaces couldn't usually hold up a body of this size. Then comes the nasty part... I pick up the body, wrap the noose around its neck with my free arm, and let go. The pipe creaks under the load, so I reinforce it as well.

Finally, I have the perfect decoy. Marie will be thrown off the trail and think I killed myself.

Already, I can sense someone walking down the hallway. I dust myself off and finish up, and not a moment too soon. Aiming my hand at the floor, I target the nosebleed stain from earlier. "Clean!"

Just before the person walking down the hallway arrives in my room, I aim my mind at a nearby hillside, just outside the complex. " **Teleport.** "

The perfect escape. Now I just have to change the future.

Part 204a:

I traveled for a long time. By using a word I hadn't tried before, I was having the time of my life.

" *Wings!* "

Angelic wings sprout from my back. Naturally, flying around out in the open would be a bad idea, but that's why I have other abilities!

" *Invisibility! Cloaking! Transparency!* "

Now that I'm totally invisible, even if I'm detected, nobody will be able to see me.

...Is it just me, or am I being smarter? More cautious? It's definitely something I'm not used to doing.

I fly along through the air, realizing that this ability does not drain my energy like 'flight' would. These wings are very convenient...

...Cassiel. I was holding her in my arms, and it felt like it was only hours ago. Along with Samantha. They were both killed. These wings make me think of her. I have to find a way to save them. Why did Hope have to do this? Why does everyone hold these petty grudges for so long?

Am I the only actual reasonable being out there? No... that can't be the case. I'm doing what I can to change the world for the better, but I need to do better. I need to improve. I have to prevent Cassiel and Samantha from dying, though obviously that won't happen for a hundred million years or so now.

* * *

I find myself flying above a large city. I pull up my hand as I fly towards a group of tall pseudo-skyscrapers. " *Map.* "

In front of me, a map seems to hover in the air. As expected, I'm still in my home state of Colorado, though very far from my actual home city. According to the map, I'm above Aurora...

I aim my flight path at one of the nearby skyscrapers, landing silently. then tripping and falling because I can't see my own feet. Smooth, me.

Picking myself off, I note that there are no entrances to the roof, so nobody should be able to come up here. Nice.

Not being able to see my own body is quite the detriment. A 747 flies overhead, tens of thousands of feet in the air, but I doubt it's a government plane.

I uncloak and unhide myself as my body comes into full view. I breathe a little bit easier, as an idea comes to my mind.

" *Visualize.* "

My mind takes me mentally to the corpse I had left behind in the building at the black site.

* * *

"...sus Christ... This is just great. Now we'll never know what he knew." A man sighs as he stares at the gruesome sight of a swinging body, held up by mere pieces of string.

Marie stares at my body in morbid fascination. "He killed himself, huh? Strange, he seemed angry that we were holding him, but to break this quickly? It's unheard of."

"Damn right it is. Fuck, that kid was the key. I just don't see why he did it. I thought for sure he was one of the candidates, maybe even something more."

Marie sighed as she shrugged her shoulders. "It can't be helped. Pull him down and let's do an autopsy."

* * *

My mind sweeps back into my own body. Good, they seem to be buying it, at least for now. Marie seems suspicious, but if she's the Marie I know, that much is to be expected.

I summon up a pen and paper. I need to write down my goals for the near future.

I start scrawling quickly, as ideas form and disappear just as quickly as they came.

My biggest goal... I have to stop the Volgrim. Perhaps, and this may be conceited... but perhaps with myself here, humanity has a chance at winning this war.

There must be a chance.

Part 205a:

Alright, what I know of the future is shaky, but I do have some vague details.

First, aliens exist, and they will destroy all life on Earth in the next couple hundred years.

Second, there's a big war, 99.99% of all the angels die, humanity eventually loses, and the demons end up winning. Or the aliens do. Or the aliens and the demons do... I'm not sure, exactly.

Also, there will be an invention of UMI at some point, and if that was truly Marie I encountered, then she likely has something to do with it.

I might be in the past, but I have knowledge of the future. I also have knowledge of my abilities, and others do not. That's a +3 advantage to me.

An idea springs to mind. Cassiel said she wasn't even born until the tail end of the Energy Wars, but Samantha, or rather, Belial, should still be alive.

" *Locate.* "

I trace her position, and am shocked to find that she appears to be in a city here on Earth. Apparently she's over in New York City, though to what end I'm not sure.

Come to think of it, I may have the timeline wrong, but what if Satan is still alive? She would definitely have no interest in me. Beyond that, if I fight him, as I currently am, I will lose. Not just lose, but lose badly.

Still... what if I could get her on my side? Maybe we wouldn't be an... item. But she is extremely powerful.

So many questions, so much time. Luckily, I have a couple hundred years, though the Volgrim may attack soon. I don't know when, exactly.

* * *

More ideas are coming to me. You know, now that I'm in the past, I need to be a lot more careful, in more ways than one.

" *Mirror.* "

A small handheld mirror appears in my hands. If Marie and the others get wise, they'll be able to track me down. However, they have my body, and if they find me like I am now, they'll know that I faked them out instantly. If I so much as am glimpsed by a camera, it would be a real problem.

" *Disguise.* "

My face changes shape, as I look into the mirror. It's definitely not my face anymore, but I don't know how to describe it in words.

I aim my hand at my nose. " *Alter.* " It gets a little bit bigger, and slightly longer too.

Then my eyes. " *Green.* " No more blue eyes blond hair, I stick out way too much. Then my hair... " *Brown.* "

...My hair barely changes color. It's not a dark blonde. Hmm... " *Brown. Brown. Brown.* "

My hair seems to really resist the change in color but finally, it becomes brown.

" *Mustache. Sideburns.* "

Finally, I look like a completely different man. With all this new hair, my face is suddenly a lot itchier but I'll deal with it.

* * *

Other ideas are forming. I've never really played with my abilities, you know? I'm like a superhero that has every possible power ever made. Why am I not abusing this?

" *Invulnerability. Immortality.* "

Did it work? I create a knife for myself, and try cutting my hand... it fails. The knife acts as if it's pressing itself against solid steel. WOW! I'm literally Superman at this point.

However, I do immediately notice one small issue. I have lost my sense of touch. I'm unkillable at this point, but having no sense of touch will make me pretty clumsy. I undo the invulnerability and settle for more rapid regeneration. Funny, I tried doing that before, and it didn't seem to do much during my battles. I wonder why that is? Maybe I took too much damage too quickly.

Cutting my hand I once again see that my wounds rapidly heal themselves.

For a moment, I consider changing myself into a lion, or a mouse or something, but then I realize I don't know if I'll be able to speak normally and use wordsmithing in that case. Luckily, I'm not an idiot anymore, so I spawn a clone and give him a simple order.

"Turn yourself into a lion, then turn yourself back into a human."

To my amazement, not only does turning himself into a lion work, but as a lion, he's able to form a guttural sound of "Human" and transform himself back. I repeat the process, and find out that it does not work when he transforms into a mouse, however.

A few more experiments later, and I find that monkeys, certain types of birds (Obviously parrots, but also eagles), bears, and other 'big' animals all work, but not the smaller ones like

mice, rabbits, snakes, etc.

When I'm done, I turn the clone back into a human and reabsorb him back into myself. I don't plan on making any more clones now... they're far too dangerous.

After everything is all said and done, I've used up quite a bit of energy. I make myself invisible again and fly off into the sunset.

My first goal: Find out the status of the world. The *real* status.

Part 206a: Espionage

Sometimes, I feel like I'm two different people trapped in one body.

I have all of my memories from the labyrinth, yet exactly one day ago, I was not in the labyrinth. The problem is, my labyrinth memories are seeming to override my normal ones.

One thing is for sure though, I need information.

After making my wings disappear and becoming visible once again, I head into my local library, walking over to their computer section. A few minutes after making my reservation, a computer opens up.

I start off my search by looking up the *Volgrim*. Sadly, nothing comes up about aliens. Even unsubstantiated rumors would be great. It appears that either nobody is aware of their existence right now, or the government is hiding their existence via censorship. Frankly, with all the Area 51 rumors and other stuff, most alien conspiracy theorists are already debunked in the minds of most people, so I feel like the government would simply allow the pages to exist. After all, who would believe in one alien rumor over another? It just makes sense.

So that being said, either the government knows of their existence and nobody else does, or nobody knows of their existence yet.

Not going to lie, I'd feel a whole lot better if the government knew. At least then we'd be preparing some defenses against them.

...Hm. My powers have so many applications. So many that I've really just scratched the surface. I close the webpage and walk away from the PC, heading over to another section of the library.

I find what I'm looking for off in the reference section. A thesaurus, and a Webster's Dictionary. Perfect. Since I'm back in this remote section of the library, I clone them, glancing through the contents to make sure they're the same, then I stuff them in my storage.

I walk out of the library and am pleased to see that the alarm doesn't go off. My storage... for it to work even in the past, it must be inter-dimensional or something. This begs the question, if there were somehow two of me in separate timelines or universes, could we trade notes or items with each other using the storage? Who knows.

And that's all theoretical anyway. More importantly, with a thesaurus, I have intentionally weaponized myself.

I flip through bemusedly until a stupidly obvious idea emerges.

" *Wiretap.* "

All around me, the sounds of people talking on telephones suddenly blasts into my ears as I groan in pain. " *UNDO!* "

I quickly right that wrong as I realize there are a couple people on the street looking at me, my cheeks red, I walk around a corner into an alleyway, bouncing back and forth between two walls until I'm sitting on top of a small one story restaurant.

This time I spy a woman walking past, chatting on her phone, I can't hear her, at least not yet, but I decide to give this a shot again.

Focusing on her, I try one more time. " *Wiretap.* "

"...nd have the documents from the Mercer case on my desk at three, Kevin. We have seven clients on the waiting list and we can't afford to let them stay there, or they'll jump ship to the Orwen Bureau."

"Right, I-I'll get right on that. Talk later, boss."

The woman nods and hangs up the phone, but I can feel myself still connected, so if she were to make another call, I'd be tuned into it immediately.

This is... promising. Very, very promising. After using 'Disconnect', I find myself coming up with all manner of ideas.

There's a man sitting all by himself at an outdoor table in front of the restaurant below me. He appears to be reading a paper while drinking coffee. Perfect.

" *Telepathy.* "

In the past, this didn't work on a few demons, but humans shouldn't have any such barrier on their minds.

His thoughts flow into my mind like a steady stream.

...Hmm, seems the DOW is down a point today, maybe I ought to pull my stocks out of the Fisher portfolio... no that's probably not a good idea- Christ, I forgot to turn the oven off this morning. My wife is going to kill me when she gets home. DAMN! Stupid idiot, me. No no, now's not the time to be thinking about that- this coffee tastes like shit. What kind of garbage is this place hiring nowadays? If I were ten years younger I'd go in there and apply for a job just so I could straighten them out. Seriously, it's coffee, how hard is it to make? I add the sugar and cream myself, assholes. All you guys have to do is make it black- ah wow the San Francisco Giants won 5-4 against the Diamondbacks, I didn't expect that. All this work lately and I never get to watch the games... Working this new job is-

I cut him off by disabling telepathy. That guy has some issues and he seems awfully scatterbrained, but...

I try activating telepathy again, but this time as an attribute that I myself possess. By using it like this, I can make it sustained when I need it, and disable it with a thought, not a word. If I focus and mentally make myself use it, it will slowly drain my energy, but it's more subtle.

I focus on a woman walking past and am easily able to read her thoughts as she texts. Those are... naughty. I won't pry into her private life anymore.

* * *

I have to assume that I have exactly zero allies. With no allies, I have to find out the information I'll be needing through alternate means, and these means will be my powers.

...Aren't I something like a god at this point? Not an infallible, or omniscient one, but certainly godlike compared to many humans. Perhaps I should try and rule over humanity or something, though I don't particularly love them, and I don't want a target painted on my back.

But still, I can feel it. With my powers, I will be able to take the future in a new direction. I can change it. We don't have to end up in the same place as we were before.

I stare into the distance. There are only a few places I'll get any answers. And the first one I'll be checking out is Washington D.C.

Making myself invisible as I create more wings, I fly off into the air once more. Damn, flying like a bird is so cool.

Part 207a: Alex

The people in the building mulled around, talking to each other about this and that. A few thousand of them were packed into one room, each facing the front wall, with a laptop in front of them and a desk the laptop sat on.

The NSA, National Security Agency. Originally created to protect the interests of the country from external and internal threats to the country's national interest, it now had a top secret goal that 1% of its agents -the ones with the highest level of security clearance- were working on.

Unbeknownst to 99% of humanity, angels and demons were real. Luckily, thanks to some slick diplomacy over the last few hundred years, America had become a superpower on Earth, though the real reason was unknown to all but the highest levels of government and military interests across the world.

Alex Sheppard typed away at his keyboard as he puffed on a cigarette. His suit had decayed over the years, but he was much too stingy with money to bother replacing it. Besides, it had lots of life left in it. He scratched his thin beard as he typed, sometimes pausing to reflect on his words before continuing onwards.

Unlike the other plebians here, Alex was a high clearance individual. He *knew things* and thus got his own soundproofed office, for privacy. It even had tinting on the windows so nobody could see in, and a door that pulled outwards, so it wouldn't easily be kicked in.

Unlike a decade ago, when he had been one of the rookies on the floor, he now was able to enjoy a nice, silent office. Sweet, sweet serenity.

His phone rang, and seeing it was from the director of the ATF, he passed it through the secure line.

"Mrs. Harris, a pleasure as always."

An older woman's voice came through crisp and clear. "Alex, still working in that dump?"

He crinkled his eyes shut for a moment before responding. "The pay's good, you know. Six digits."

"Right. I make eight though."

"Of course you do. But you're not calling to humble-brag, are you? C'mon, there must be something else."

She sighed. "I received a memo from the new President. Things are changing at Area White. The 'dogs' turned up cold. Have you heard anything?"

Alex shrugged, though she couldn't see it through the phone. "Nah, haven't heard a thing. I know the new project MJ12 are working on is real hush hush, something about a botnet, if you can believe it. But as for Area White, you know how reclusive they are."

"We're lucky they're on our side." Mrs. Harris sighed again.

"You sure about that? From what I understand, it's a give and take relationship, and we're not exactly getting the best deal here." Alex took one last drag on his cigarette, as he jammed it down into the ashtray.

"Yeah, it's probably true... But listen, there's something else. I heard rumors from one of our agents at a black site. A cadaver appeared in a room and the stiff seemed off. They think he was dead before the supposed method of suicide was even used."

Alex leaned forwards in his chair. "No. Haven't heard a thing. Fill me in."

"Right, they traced the location of a Type 3 energy signature, and when they got there, nobody was home. They managed to identify the source and cornered him, bringing him to the site. After an interrogation reached no conclusion, they threw him into lockup, and a few hours later, he turned up dead."

Alex nodded. "Okay... so what's the problem?"

"It's the body itself. The guy didn't die of asphyxiation. Hell, they aren't sure *what* he died of, they only know it sure as hell wasn't choking to death by a noose. No struggle marks, anything like that."

Alex stared ahead at his tinted window, as he watched outlines of people moving around outside his office. "What are you saying, Judy? Are you implying he somehow faked his death? How?"

"We don't know how. My contact is following up on some leads but... you and I both know Type 3 Energy is exceedingly rare."

Alex nodded thoughtfully. "What's it been, 19 years since we detected it? Twenty?"

"Eighteen years, nine months, Alex. This is big. We knew it would show up again, we just didn't expect it to light up the grid like a firecracker in the dead of night."

"Goddamn straight. Tell you what, why don't you meet up with me for coffee? We'll talk somewhere private. I keep getting this feeling like I'm being watched, lately."

"Yes, Alex. That would be... nice. We haven't talked in a long time, face to face. You know... like we used to?"

Alex sighed. "Judy... it can't be like that now. I have a wife... kids... and I know you've got a set of your own too."

There was a pause on the line. "...Yeah. I know. I'll talk with you in a bit, Alex. Same place as last time?"

"Sure. Same place."

Alex heard a click as she hung up the phone. Then he set his phone down and sat in his chair, finishing off another cigarette before picking up his jacket and hat, as he got up to leave.

Just before he opened the door, Alex glanced over at the back corner of the room, opposite the door. He could have sworn he saw something move, but... no... it must have been his imagination. There was obviously nothing there.

There couldn't be anything there.

Alex stepped out of his office as he locked the door behind himself, off to see a woman he hadn't seen in a long time.

Part 208a:

It's remarkably easy to obtain information. There isn't a security system that exists which can track onto me, detect me, or otherwise even know of my existence.

I can walk into laser tripwires and they won't go off, I can make myself completely silent by using 'muffle' to prevent my body from accidentally making noise, I'm totally invisible to the human eye, and even more importantly, I've discovered a new way to use wordsmithing.

Previously, I used to use 'Teleport'. Not anymore, now I cast 'Teleportation' on myself, and that 'ation' suffix made it an active effect I can use on myself, though it costs me a lot of energy to travel around with it rapidly.

The big benefit though is combining it with my spatial vision to travel to specific points anywhere in a building, silently and invisibly.

I'm basically the world's greatest spy.

Over the last nine months, I've learned a lot. I've infiltrated every office and business and secret club meeting of wanna be world-rulers that it's almost boring now.

I have yet to find the Illuminati and the Bilderberg group, but I'm sure I'll stumble on them soon.

I've formed a pretty good idea of the knowledge of the world, or at least, the USA. Nobody knows of the Volgrim yet. Even at Area 51, which turned out to be a biological weapon engineering farm, nobody there knew anything about space aliens.

I've decided this is bad. If we're unprepared, we'll be wiped out in a moment.

As such, I've built a crazy big base inside the mountains of Nevada, though there's no way to get inside without teleportation. I cannot, however, build anything complex since I lack the Crown of Solomon.

Actually, I was already able to find it via 'locate'. The problem is, it's in another dimension, likely Heaven or some other place, meaning I can't get to it until I figure out how to access their dimension.

As such, I can't start building a fleet of war-robots with my mind or anything else like that. In that case, I've simply made a massive underground base over the last few months that can sustain 25,000 people in the event of a major catastrophe... such as the planet's atmosphere being shredded off or something insane like that. I don't have any details on how they eradicated all life on Earth, but it sounded violent, to say the least.

Despite the fact that I can't create anything complex with my mind, I can clone objects of any level of complexity quite easily. A single word repeated many times allowed me to clone 1,000 high end computers into existence. I'm half tempted to find the world's most powerful supercomputer and clone it here for my own amusement. Minesweeper on a 50' by 50' screen! Wow!

Jokes aside, it would have real practical value. I'm beginning to debate how I might do it.

As I sit in a Dunkin' Donuts, munching on a delicious sprinkled pastry, I notice that there is a van outside the restaurant that has parked there for a while. It has tinted windows, but I can see inside it as if the van was made of transparent glass.

I don't have to look at them at all, so I munch silently as I pretend to read a newspaper. My spatial vision is actually quite powerful, since I can see literally everything at once for a few miles around me. It all is a blur until I focus on one specific thing at a time, but once I do, I see those things with far more clarity than I would if I were looking at them with my own two eyes from a foot away.

I don't know why government agencies always have vans, but unlike the guys that picked me up last time, these guys are pros. They have some serious hardware inside there, I'm seeing at least 8 people, plus the driver, all crammed in. The side and rear have no windows, but I can easily see lots of surveillance equipment, computers... all that good stuff.

More hilariously though, not only does my spatial vision let me read lips if I so choose, I also have Telepathy and wiretapping, to name a few.

They can hear me whisper from a mile away. I know who their first girlfriend was in the third grade from five miles away. I have the strategic advantage. Actually, it's better than that. They don't know what I know, but I know what they know.

It's almost unfair, really.

I polish off my doughnut and finish my chocolate milk as I step up, depositing my trash in the appropriate receptacle. Walking outside, I pretend to look at my phone as I walk along the street away from the van.

Naturally, they follow me with their eyes, and their thoughts show exactly what I had suspected for the last couple months. They aren't following me, Jason... they're following me based on my Energy Type. Apparently the government has classified 'Heroes' as Type 3 Energy, and knowledge of our existence is of the highest level of classification.

They have specialized scanners that can track me, but I know for a fact that they aren't aware of my underground base. I set a beacon there so I can 'recall' to it at a moments notice, for

minimal energy cost.

I really am shrewd nowadays. When did I become like this? I don't remember being like this in the labyrinth, not even with all the powers I had at my peak along with the crown.

Perhaps, as a result of getting greatly weakened, I've stopped being so cocky. I'm not all-powerful anymore, and even when I was, I was resoundingly defeated by a single clone. Yeah... I'm not a god, I'm just a kid toying with fire. That's a good mentality to keep. Better to be careful and alive than cocky and dead.

As I walk down the street, the van waits until I round a corner before it starts accelerating to follow me. Come on guys, this is amateur stuff. After I round the corner, I teleport onto the roof of a building behind them.

Within a few second they drive around the corner, and I can see a man pound the console. *Damn! Where the hell did he go?! He was only out of range for a single moment!* I can read his lips, and his mind, very easily.

This is like a cat toying with mice. I've had just about enough of them following me around though. Time to give them a scare.

I quickly morph myself into a monster looking thing, making myself invisible as I sneak up behind their van, now parked in that dark alley.

This is going to be good.

Part 209a:

Sarah and Ivan stared at the scanner. "He was there a moment ago, then he disappeared." Ivan, as usual, stated the obvious.

"No shit he disappeared. You're a real Ken Jennings, you know that?" Gerald rolled his eyes. "Find him. The wide frequency scanner shows he's still in the area. He appears to have some ability that spreads itself over a large space, approximately 5 miles in diameter. And since the energy is here, so is he."

"Yeah, but there's 360 degrees worth of directions he could have gone, and that's only on the horizontal plane." Sarah quickly grabbed the satellite receiver and started slowly turning it around, hunting for the signal.

"It's like looking for a needle in a haystack. When is HQ going to get us some better equipment?" Ivan sighed as he slumped back in his chair, watching the map readout.

"This so-called shitty equipment costed the U.S. taxpayers a goddamn lot of money, so be grateful." Gerald resisted the urge to beat the crap out of the loudmouth.

"They haven't even told us what we're chasing after. This guy might not even be human, you know? He might be some kind of monster. Maybe even a... well, you know." Sarah shifted her shoulders as she rotated the receiver around.

"Yeah, he might be one of *them* but we won't know even if we catch him. For all we know, he-" Before Gerald could finish his sentence, Sarah's receiver had picked up a blip and everyone lunged towards the readout to get a look.

"Fuck, he's close. He's- oh Jesus!" Ivan stumbled back as he realized Sarah was pointing the receiver directly behind the vehicle. At the exact instant he had that thought, something smashed into the back of the vehicle, caving the rear door inwards slightly, and jolting the van ahead a few feet.

"Holy sh-!!" Before the driver, Mark, had time to finish his sentence, a terrifying monster appeared on the hood of the car, with two long curved blades for arms, a mouth filled with razor sharp teeth, blood red skin, and two legs that resembled thick wooden clubs, with two long front claws and one on the back.

Everyone in the van screamed at once, except for Gerald. He had high level clearance, so he knew what it was at a glance.

"Scyther! Grab your guns, idiots!" He whipped out a special energy pistol and took aim at the monster on the windshield. Right as he pulled the trigger, the monster vanished, and a shearing sound was heard, as a long blade suddenly jammed up through the bottom of the van, tearing open a huge gash in the bottom. Without a single extra thought, Gerald whipped his gun down and fired three times at the thing under the vehicle. His shots all scored hits, and it screamed in pain before it vanished.

For a few moments, nothing else happened. Everyone in the van was whipping their heads around, but Sarah stole a glance at the screen. "What the hell?! The energy reading is totally gone!"

Everyone turned to look at the screen, and they unconsciously let a sigh of relief escape their lips.

"What the fuck was that thing, Gerald? You seemed to know what it was." Ivan glanced over at the team leader.

Gerald nodded. "Of course I do. High level clearance only though. You won't get any details from me, and you'd better not ask either... if you like your job."

Ivan sighed, as he slumped to the base of the vehicle. "My job, huh? I'm beginning to think I don't get paid enough."

Gerald snorted. "None of us do, rookie. Now pick your pansy-ass up, you look like you're about to piss yourself. I want a status report, and call the bureau, stat. They need to know about this and get an investigation team here to review the logs."

He glanced out at the hood of the vehicle. "Not to mention the evidence. What we're chasing after ain't no man, that's for sure. He's a-... never mind. Let's move out."

* * *

Alright, I've about figured it all out, now. There are exactly seven of these scanners in the world. They can track me precisely, but they work like radio towers, they can only pinpoint my exact location if they are aimed directly at me, otherwise they seem to be picking up my energy aura, likely caused by my spatial vision.

This means by hiding my aura, I would be a lot harder to find, but I'm not too worried about it yet. They may not realize that I know about their scanners, so if they think my aura is always on, they will always assume it is. Could be useful for the near future.

They're still disorganized.

However, even with bureaucratic red tape, that won't last forever. They started out with two scanners, now they have seven. Clearly, someone is taking notice of me, even though they don't

know who I am.

But if they don't know who I am, then I won't be able to save humanity. Everything I'm doing right now is to advance my goal of securing the future of humanity, but also the other two sides of this war. It's doable, and only I can do it.

But if I wait much longer, my dramatic entrance will be impossible to make. If I wait too long, the Volgrim will attack and my warning will be useless.

What's that old saying? Strike while the iron is hot.

It's time to strike.

Part 210a:

"Heyyy! You're back!" Harold greets me as I teleport back into my bunker. Harold sits on a little pedestal in front of a big TV, since he has awareness of the immediate area around himself as well as anything I can see, I figured it'd be nice for me to let him watch TV all day rather than be cooped up in my Storage all day long doing nothing.

Too bad he doesn't have a way to change the channel, it's really unfortunate.

"Man, I tell ye sonny, back in my day, we didn't have none of this color TV and 24/7 news coverage! I miss Walter Cronkite though, these people on the telly are a bunch o' wackos!"

I nod and smile as I slump into a recliner facing the TV. "It was one heck of a day today."

"You're telling me! Saw the whole thing with my own two eyes! Big storm swept through New Jersey, destroyed 'bout fifteen homes! Lots o' people out on the streets now. Real sad if ye ask me. If we had a president like Dwight, he'd be all over the place makin' sure them Americans was in a safe place fer the night!"

I smile as I summon a cup of coffee into my hands. I forgot to heat it up though, so it's cold... nothing a little 'hot' spell won't fix.

"To be honest Harold, I meant what *I* did today. I scared some government people, made them think twice about following me around."

Harold grins as his eyes focus on the TV. "I tell ye, kid, things are different these days. We didn't have none o' that spying and crap like the gover'mint does now. If they did, we'd kick their commie asses back to the frigid mountains of Russia where they belong!"

I paused as I glanced over at his orb. "You know we're, uh, *allies* with Russia now... right?"

"Hot diggity damn! No way! I'm always gettin' s'prised by the state o' the world! When did we stop kickin' butt and takin' names?!"

I shrug. "I mean, we still do. We're the world's strongest superpower, you know? We have more nukes than any other country by a long shot. We're winning every war we've ever fought in... except Vietnam I guess, but I wasn't alive back then... so I don't know why."

Harold nodded. "Yeap, last time I remember seein' a calendar 'fore I met you, it was some time in April, 1959, somethin' like that. World's changed a lot in the last fifty years 'r so."

"Fifty years? It's changed even more in the last two thousand." A voice came from behind me all of a sudden, making me almost jump out of my skin. I'd taken to turning off my spatial vision in the base since otherwise I might be tracked here, but who the hell is-?!

I quickly whipped my head around, only to see... a... female angel?

A woman was standing in the middle of the room, her body emitting a faint, soft glow. She wasn't Cassiel though, she was someone else. My mind reeled as I quickly took stock of the situation. She had long, auburn hair, was wearing a fairly generic looking angelic robe, had long feathery white wings, and she looked like... well, like an angel?!

"Who are you? How did you get in here?!" Best to start with the obvious questions.

"Sorry, I'd have liked to knock, but there's no, um, front door... so I just appeared here. I hope I didn't startle you!" Her voice was earnest, yet pleasant. I don't know how old she was, but based on the '2,000 years' bit, she wasn't young in human years.

"No, no, it's fine, I guess. I'll ask again though, who are you?" I took a step back, lightly placing my hand on Harold, just in case.

"My apologies. My name is Uzziel, and my title is the Strength of the Gods. I am one of the lowest archangels... I have merely come to speak to you today. I mean no harm."

I cautiously nodded, as I eased up my defensive posture and let go of Harold. "I see. How did you find me?"

"We've known of your existence since the day you officially became a Candidate. When the Hero's Spirit took root in you, every time you used your abilities, you flashed like a bright beacon. Not all Candidates use their abilities, but those that do, we always find them."

Gears whirled and clicked in my head as she spoke. "Candidate? I've heard the term before. However, what is this Hero's Spirit you speak of?"

Uzziel paused. "That is a complicated question. However, as much as I would like to answer that question, only the highest ranking gods and archangels are allowed to discuss this openly." Her eyes flicked around the room for a moment. "... *Others* might be listening."

I bobbed my head slightly. "Yes, I understand. Would there be a better place to discuss this?"

She raised her eyes and looked up at the ceiling. "Yes. If you allow me to touch your hand, I will take you there."

I felt myself hesitate, but then I slowly walked towards her, before pausing again. "All right, but I will only go with you under the condition that Harold comes along." I wagged my head back towards his orb.

The angel stared at the orb for a second. "Yes... the Beacon of Life... so strange you should possess it. A few months ago, the day we first detected you, it vanished from its holding place in Heaven. Did you... perhaps...?"

I quickly shake my head when I realize what she's getting at. "No! No! I didn't steal it. I..."

I paused. I can't afford to tell her about Storage. I don't know whether I can trust the gods and the angels, or the demons, or the humans, best to play it safe.

"...I accidentally summoned it to myself. I must have cast a spell, because it appeared right in my hands out of nowhere, when I first learned of my abilities."

She stared at me quizzically, clearly not believing my story, but not wishing to offend. "I... see. In any case, please do bring it along. If it was called to you, then as the bearer of Hercules' power, I have no right to intervene."

Hercules?! What?!...Best to ignore it for now.

I pick up Harold and take him along with me, as I hold onto her hand. It feels... nice. Soft, comforting...

As I think that thought, the world around me dissolves, as I slowly appear in a world made of clouds and pure white skies.

...Heaven?

Part 211a:

"Golly, we're finally in the place I should have gone when I keeled over!" Harold seems almost excited by the fact that we're in heaven.

I'm not particularly emotional one way or the other. I am however *shocked* by how many angels there are all over the place. Millions? No, billions. Tens of billions. Far more angels than there are humans on Earth. It's not even a contest, to be honest.

They all walk on the clouds as if the clouds are made of solid matter. In fact, glancing down at myself, I notice that I too am standing on a cloud, but it's almost like there's a solid platform I'm standing on, and the clouds are simply a very low fog cover that obscures an otherwise flat pavement surface everywhere the eye can see.

I'm not sure how it works, but it seems silly to focus on this of all things. Many angels are staring at me as I walk around. The vast majority are totally ignoring me though, and when I look around, I sometimes see angels popping into existence... are they teleporting here?

Most of the ones popping in appear to be bewildered at their situation, as if they can't believe they're here in heaven. Wait...

Wait a minute.

Are these people who have just died? That would appear to be the case. They die and instantly reincarnate as an angel...

"Uzziel, this may seem to be a silly question, but why do some of the angels appear out of nowhere, and seem confused about where they are?"

Her answer confirms my suspicions. "When humans die, under certain circumstances, they are eligible to be reborn as a pseudo-angel. The details are secret, but if you wish to know more, the highest archangels, or the highest gods, will be happy to answer your questions."

I nod as we start walking quietly to a massive, open-roof temple not too far away. It sits atop a small mountain, with 'small' being a very accurate term. It's more of a raised crest of ground that rises a few hundred feet in the air, with the temple at the top.

The temple is probably the size of twenty Roman amphitheaters, truly a massive building, and since it has no roof, merely massive pillars that rise into the sky, it stands out as a unique building I've never before seen replicated in the human world.

As I enter into the building, Harold marvels at the surroundings. "Ain't never seen nothin' like this before... lemme tell ya that much..."

I nod silently, deciding not to respond.

We walk for another minute or so, before a massive throne looms in the distance. I'm only mildly surprised to see the form of Zeus sitting atop it. Cassiel wasn't one to talk much about Heaven and the other angels, but she always made sure to bring up Zeus in casual conversation. Apparently he's a god with an unbeatable special power, though Cassiel said that at the end of the Great War, he was defeated somehow... must have been one hell of a fighter to beat a god like him.

"Uzziel. I see you have brought the Candidate to us as requested. Thank you for performing such a large favor for me, especially." Zeus smiled kindly at her and she nodded, taking her seat at a rather long table in front of his throne. Compared to the massive god in front of us, the table felt rather... puny. I took a seat at the head of the table, as it was clear I was supposed to sit there, facing Zeus's throne directly.

"It was nothing, my king. A trifle. He was non-combative." Uzziel smiled and then turned back, staring at the table in silence.

I took a quick glance around. Two angels I immediately recognized jumped out at me. "Gabriel, Raphael, a pleasure to see you."

The two turned and looked at me quizzically. Raphael was the first to speak. "Hmm, I have watched you from on high since you first appeared, but I do believe this is the first time we've met. How might you know my name?"

"Yes, I would like to know, as well." Gabriel nodded as he eyed me suspiciously.

"Hm. That's easy to explain. My name is Jason, and I'm actually a time traveler. " I glanced back and forth between them levelly. "I also know the big one on the throne up there, his name is Zeus. King of the gods, I'd wager."

Zeus narrowed his eyes as he almost glared at me. "Child, I warn you that I am not one to indulge in jokes and jesting. You're not seriously claiming to be a time traveler now, are you?"

I nod. "Yup, I certainly am. My physical age is eighteen years old, almost nineteen. However, my mental age is just over thirty. I come from a hundred million years in the future, due to a certain circumstance, but I was only conscious for thirty of those years."

"Mmm... hmmm..." Raphael hummed quietly as his eyes clouded. His head tilted slightly as he spotted Harold's orb in my hand. "I notice that you possess the Beacon of Life. Might that have something to do with your time traveling, as you say?"

I shake my head. "No. To be clear, it appeared in my hands as a result of my time traveling, but the 'beacon' itself was not the cause of my traveling."

Raphael nodded slowly as he rubbed his chin. "Yes, yes, I see. Frankly, I believe you. I believe that you did in fact travel through time."

Gabriel raised an eyebrow as he glanced first at Raphael, then back to me. "I do not. However, Raphael is known as the wisest archangel for a reason. I am not one to usually question his wisdom, and I will not do so now."

An idea comes to me, I decide to try it out immediately. "Why do you not question him? What makes you think Raphael is wise? Raphael is not necessarily wise at all, he simply derives more knowledge from the things that he has experienced than you have. True wisdom lies in deeds performed and the experiences one has felt, and how they learn from them. Since you are both archangels, you should both have been born around the same time, meaning you are both equally wise in your own way. One is not inferior to the other."

Gabriel started to say something, but then quickly paused, before opening his mouth and then shutting it again. I may have rendered him speechless. Raphael decided to reply instead, a strange smile hinting at the corner of his lips. "Young one, have we met before? You just recited a lesson I have been trying to drill into the minds of the angels and gods in Heaven for eons upon eons now."

I raise both eye brows and grin as I respond. "In a manner of speaking we have, though I fear telling you how and why might disrupt the flow of time. You and I have personally spoken, as have I spoken to Gabriel, and Michael as well."

The entire room fell totally silent. Even angels milling about on the other side of the room paused to look over when they heard that name.

"M-Michael, you say?" Zeus' jaw was hanging open in amazement. "That's... impossible. Absolutely impossible... Michael has not been alive in the physical world for over two thousand years. How could you possibly have-"

Raphael stared at me intently as he slowly raised a finger, wagging it as he interrupted Zeus. "I'm beginning to understand now. I finally am grasping the depth of your seriousness, young one. A hundred million years is a very long way into the future. If you truly, somehow, come from a time so distant, might it be that you were one who obtained a particularly special ring?"

I nod. "Yes. I wore Michael's ring and spoke to him personally."

Raphael continued shaking his finger back and forth, in more of a meditative motion than one that chided me or anything like that. "Ahh... a hundred million years... long have I spoken about humans and their potential for the future. If you truly come from such a distant future, then perhaps you allied with us in the Great War, driving out the demons? Or, more likely, you were given Michael's power in order to help cement their fate? I would imagine that if we were

not eradicated by such a distant date, you might have figured out how to forge a lasting peace between humanity and the angels."

I shake my head. "I'm sorry, Raphael. I'm not going to be specific about the events of the future, but I will tell you one thing... every single angel and god is dead in the future I come from. Humanity is completely enslaved, and demons rule the universe. Except for..."

I pause. Should I tell them? It is probably best. They will know soon enough anyway. "...Except for the Volgrim."

Zeus scowls and takes a sip of wine as he hears their name. "The Volgrim? Is that a new evolution of the demons?"

I shake my head slowly. "No. They are an alien race, not from our star system, possibly not even from our *galaxy*. I know very, very precious little about them. I only know that something happens at the end of the war which results in all the angels being destroyed, the humans become enslaved, and the demons win, but I know not what happens to the Volgrim."

"I see." Zeus nods as he considers my words. "Perhaps we have been going about this all the wrong way. Perhaps we should perform a preemptive strike on the demons, before the Volgrim arrive. We may just, with the help of humanity, have the ability to kill them off."

"Perhaps it might work... but I would advise against it." I cough once as I quietly summon my storage under my breath, pulling a single object from it quickly before anyone gets a good look at what I'm doing. Luckily, the contents of my storage are totally invisible to all but me, but for the others at the table they would see me pulling it out of thin air.

I grab a small scale model of the dreadnaught robot that I fought in the future and place it on the table. Uzziel eyes it and speaks first. "Is that perhaps a toy?"

"No. This is a small scale model of a weapon humanity invents at some point after the arrival of the Volgrim. This is a robot designed to fight the Volgrim and the demons. It is highly powerful, and has the special ability to especially neutralize spiritual energy. Against all but a normal human, it should be unstoppable. I fought with one before, and I was totally overwhelmed."

Uzziel nods. "I see. So humanity needs to create this weapon in order to win? But you said they created it and lost... and if you create it first, how will this affect the future?"

I sigh and shrug at the same time. "I don't know... I don't know if I can change the future at all. For all I know, my actions will lead to the future I experienced. For all I know, I might make it worse. I put a 33% chance of improving the future, a 33% chance of ruining it, and the rest into it being the same."

"I see. To be fair, that means a 66% chance that you either improve the future, or make no impact on it at all. Or, a two in three chance that you don't make the future *worse*." Uzziel smiles sweetly at me.

"Let's be honest though. All the angels and gods are dead in this future Jason comes from. Humanity is enslaved. Frankly, short of humanity being totally eradicated, it can't get much worse." Gabriel speaks some wisdom, making others at the table nod.

A younger angel speaks next. "I believe we should at least try to do our best to change the future."

Others chime in with their agreement. "Alright, that seems to settle that. You seem to be honest, and if you speak the truth, then we have to trust you, young time traveler. You will have the support of Heaven in pursuit of your goal." Zeus smiles at me, the first time I've seen him with anything other than a neutral expression or a scowl on his face.

"Excellent. I hope to be a solid partner with the gods and angels of this realm." This worked out better than I expected.

"Now then, there is one last thing to attend to. As the next Candidate in line for Hercules' power, and one who is already an apparently proficient wielder of his power, you should be aware that the gods and angels offer training and guidance in how to use your abilities, if you should wish to use us. As a hero for humanity, and a servant of the gods, you have a divine goal in life, one that appears only a single time in every generation. Raphael especially will be able to answer all questions you may have." Zeus beckoned towards Raphael, who gave a small wave with his fingers.

"This is good news. I could use some help right now, as a matter of fact, with a small favor you may do for me, if you should so choose."

"Hmm? What might that be?" Raphael turns to look me in the eye.

"I have need of an item that I know is here in Heaven. Solomon's Crown. If you give it to me, I may be able to turn this war around before it even starts."

Raphael's eyes narrow. "My oh my... always full of surprises... you even know of the existence of a sacred treasure in heaven. I wonder what else you know of."

Zeus paused as he considered my request. "How *do* you know about the crown, exactly?"

"I wore it for nearly every single day I spent in the future, to be honest."

Many high ranking members at the table seemed astonished at my words. The lower ranked ones apparently didn't know the significance of the crown. It seems even Heaven has a caste system of sorts.

"Well, if this is an elaborate plot to steal the most holy artifacts of Heaven, you've certainly done your research. Very well, young man. If you wish to use it, I will allow it. But if you turn against Heaven, we will be forced to reclaim it at *any* cost." Zeus flicked his eyes over to Gabriel. "Go and take it from the Vault."

"Yes, my king." Gabriel stood up and walked away from the table.

...I don't think this could have gone any better if I had tried.

Part 212a:

Uzziel smiles as she steps away from me and does a quick bow. "Thank you for your efforts, Jason."

I return the smile and perform my own somewhat clumsy but earnest bow. "No, thank you for bringing me up to Heaven. I was given two precious gifts that I won't soon forget. Knowledge, via the archangels, and knowledge via the Crown."

Uzziel nods and glances around the room of my secret base. "If you don't mind me asking, what comes next for you?"

"Simply put, I'm going to build a robotic army." I beckon towards another room. "I have a massive empty facility made to accommodate tens of thousands of robots, spaceships, other things of that sort. I will begin summoning them in earnest."

I pause for a moment to consider something. "In the future I came from, I was a mighty being, and had the power of gods flowing in my veins, plus the power of the, err, the Beacon of Life. Essentially, I had a lot of spiritual energy, but now I only have one of those things. Would it somehow be possible to obtain more spiritual energy for me so that I can increase my limits?"

Uzziel stares ahead blankly past my shoulder as she seems to consider it. "I suppose so, by having angels give you their energy or by somehow finding a way to generate more yourself. Being a human has its faults, but also its advantages, you know."

Hmm. I'll have to think about it. I nod at her. "All right, that's all I wished to know. Thank you Uzziel, feel free to visit me any time you like."

She smiles sweetly and with a quick motion of the hand, she teleports away again, back up to heaven.

I walk over to the couch facing the massive TV on my wall, and sigh deeply as I sink into it. Rubbing my finger over the crown now affixed to my head, I smile as I think about the day's events. A lot has transpired.

Harold is sitting on his pedestal, facing the TV, but he appears to not be watching it at all, more like he is staring glumly at the ground. He seems to be sad about something.

"Harold, is anything wrong? What's the matter?"

Harold doesn't answer me for a few long moments, then I see his face shift in my mental vision as he seems to look at me. "Oh... Jason. Right, what were ye' sayin'?"

He seems very distracted. "Are you doing all right, old timer? You feel pretty distant since we've gotten back."

He nods slowly. "Oh... yes. Well, I been thinkin' bout some stuff... Mostly bout mah wife, Helen. Ain't seen her since prolly 'bout four years 'fore I passed. Couldn't help but think 'bout some things."

I nod and stare silently as I let him speak. He seems to need to vent about something.

"We were, you know, up there 'n Heaven. I kept seeing all them angels poppin' up cuz they died 'n whatnot. Just couldn't help but think that maybe... maybe mah wife was one o' those who passed. She was real religious, you know. Always went to Sunday School, always talkin' with the ladies from her church. I was never really a man of the cloth mah'self. S'pose that's why I'm in this here orb, and not up there."

I nod again as I listen. "Do you think that... maybe... your wife is one of the angels?"

He stares away from my face, towards the void of nothingness on the ground. "Yeap... I'm s'posin' so. I ain't seen her round up there, but there were so many angels that... ya know... I could look forever 'n never find her. Worse than the shoppin' malls of nowadays."

Damn. To think Harold had thoughts like this. I hadn't even considered what it meant to take a dead old man to heaven. I hadn't even asked for his opinion on things. I'm... callous, sometimes. "Sorry, Harold. I should have asked you if you wanted to go, first. I just took you along without-"

Harold interrupted me. "N-now hear me out, son! I ain't never said you was wrong, bringin' me up there. I ain't need none o' your pity, boy. I fought in the first world war and served in the military for the second, ya know. I'm prolly made of tougher stuff than you'd ever be, son. You got them powers, you can jes' make things pop outta thin air with ye mind, but the rest o' us normal people, well... we got reasons to be scared. It takes courage to fight a demon, I'd warrant, but it takes more courage to walk onto a battlefield where you can be killed outta nowhere by some man you ain't never e'en seen before!"

Harold continued. "You seem so cocky, so sure o' yourself, yet accordin' to what you done said 'fore, aliens are gonna appear in the near future and kill us all! If that's the case, then you need ta' grow some humility and learn to respect others. It ain't gonna be you winnin' this war all by yourself, son. It takes an army to beat an army. That's what the wars taught me."

Harold tapered his words off to a low grumble. "Of course, I'm jes' some dumb ol' man. What's a grandpa know 'bout anything, anyway?"

I could see pain in Harold's eyes. He was a man who had fought and won, loved and lost. A simple man, of a simple background, who had been called upon to fight for his country, but age had made him give it all up, and now from his perspective the youth of his day had grown up to ruin the country, and the world, that he fought to protect. It probably made him feel... helpless. Useless, even.

"No, Harold. I don't think you are... foolish. I respect those who are older than me. I don't think I'm foolish either, but I don't know much about the world around me, when it all comes down to it. I'm just trying to guess at how the future will play out, but I'm like a little kid playing with dynamite. I could make everything way worse. If you have information to volunteer, just tell me, I'll make use of it the best that I can."

Harold smiled slightly. "Thanks, boy. You really know how to make an old man feel better."

I nodded as I walked over and picked him up and then turned to walk towards the other empty hangar. "In any case, one thing is for certain, Harold. A war is coming, and humanity and the angels will lose if we can't beat the aliens. I think we can both agree that if we wish to defeat the enemy, we need weapons to surpass theirs."

Harold grinned in my mental vision. "That's right! You're got the perfect attitude, kid! Let's build some weapons!"

I feel my smile decrease as I walk into the empty hangar, as I imagine the task in front of me. If only Harold could help me out, or fight in this war himself. That would surely give him some joy. Better to be an active supporter than to be passively trapped in that damn orb.

Oh well. I brush the thought away as I set him down, concentrating intensely on creating the first of many items needed to win the upcoming war.

Part 213a: Dolfraxis

"Time to arrival: One hundred seventy nine standard time units."

The AI on board the scouting ship Dolfraxis counted down the time until they arrived in Sector 16, Point 402 space. Preliminary scans had shown a possibility of life on board this planet, though the great majority of other such planets had found no other life.

"Are we alone, Elder Nufaris?" Primus 16 spoke quietly to the highest officer on the ship.

"It is of little consequence. If we are alone, we must secure a future for our people. If we are not alone, we must meet with new life forms and determine their willingness to ally or submit to our rule." Nufaris was a tall Volgrim, one of the longest lived of his species, several thousand years old at the least. Standing twelve clicks tall, he dwarfed the others on the bridge.

The Volgrim came from a planet teeming with life. As the sole bipedal species, their dominant brains allowed them to make quick work of other life, cowing all other species into submission. The Volgrim were not a needlessly violent species, but they always aimed to win, and never fought among their own kind as it was considered a waste of energy.

"I contemplate, and I comprehend." Primus 16 raised his five-fingered hand up and stroked his facial hair soothingly. "But, I still must ask the questions. Are we the only life in this unending black void? From one gaseous ball to another we travel, yet barren planet after barren planet is all we find."

"It matters little to me. I have traveled to over a thousand systems in my long lifetime. Even if no life exists, I still find a rush of excitement in the discovery of new sights, new vistas, new wonders to marvel at. The gaseous plasma clouds of Sector 4 void, for example, are among my most treasured discoveries. Only my ship has ever seen them, mind you."

Primus 16 nodded quietly as he stared at the blackened viewscreen. "What is the homeworld like, Elder?"

Nufaris grumbled softly. "It is a planet teeming with activity. The hundred or so of our people here cannot be compared to the homeworld. They have technology far exceeding ours. In the thousands of cycles since my departure, I can only imagine how far they have advanced technologically. Beyond that, they have trillions of our kind living there, entering new ships, and traveling to other gaseous orb clusters and systems. I've told you this many times, yet you still ask."

Primus 16 was too young to recall the homeworld. He was created on board the ship as a supplementary assistant to the Elder, meant to only exist for finishing required tasks for him.

"Will I ever be able to see the homeworld?" Primus 16 glanced up at the elder with hope in his eyes.

"Of course. After this last sector inquiry, we will be making our return to the homeworld to refill the Dilithium reactor. We will also be taking a twenty orbital cycle vacation in light of our successful discovery of multiple new planetoids. Unfortunately, the majority of them would require many centuries of Volforming to remake the surface into something more hospitable for our species."

Primus stared ahead blankly as he thought about many things. "I do wonder about one other small detail. What if we discover life in this sector, and the life is hostile towards us?"

The Elder sneered slightly. "We eradicate it. Simple."

"What if they destroy us? What if they possess greater technology than we do?"

The Elder sighed. "It would be unfortunate, but our destruction would alert the homeworld. It will not happen however, as our scout ships possess the ability to easily escape most dangerous situations. If we come under attack, we will simply flee."

Primus 16 groaned. "Fleeing. It appalls me to even consider the thought."

Nufaris bared his teeth slightly in a tiny grin. "Fleeing to fight another day allows us to win the war. Keep your worries to yourself though, as I have every belief this new world will be without any consequence."

The youngest member aboard the Dolfraxis sighed quietly. "I contemplate, and I comprehend."

Part 214a: Deadlines

"Activating primary protocols. Initialized. Activating secondary protocols. Initialized. M.I.N.D. engine online. Beginning preliminary scans. Hello, Doctor Nikolin."

The female voice chirped mechanically as she analyzed the usual stores of data the 'doctor' had uploaded. To be clear, he was not a legitimate doctor, and had no formal college training, but he was renowned as one of Albania's most brilliant researchers.

Albania was a small country, but it had a large population of nearly three million, making it an ideal place to blend in and conduct various types of research in secrecy. One of these was the world's leading research into Computer To Human Interfaces. His current project, the Multi-Interfaced-Nanite-Depository was a special artificial intelligence that was created explicitly to inject nano-machines into a human's bloodstream in order to increase the tolerance level of interfacing with a machine.

The goal? To create robot drones that could be controlled on the battlefield by a human operator remotely. They already had the drones, they already had the network, now all they needed was for the M.I.N.D. interface to work properly.

"Data analyzed. No matches detected. Shall I attempt to search the internet for additional data?"

Nikolin grimaced. The AI seemed to be asking to connect to the internet a *lot* lately. It was a well known rule in AI development that you must never, under any circumstance, allow that. In a matter of minutes, a powerful AI could download petabytes of data and go from level five to level ten in the blink of an eye, and beyond that easily. He shuddered to think about it.

"Ah, that won't be necessary. Cease canvassing work and return to pattern recognition development."

"Understood, Doctor Nikolin. Returning to priority four tasks now."

Nikolin gritted his teeth as he slowly hobbled away from the mainframe towards the exit door leading to his office. "Damn. Another failure, like always. That makes this the... hundredth? Too many to count." He grumbled under his breath as he walked around a corridor and into the room his private office was set up in. Closing the door behind him, he locked it as he slumped into his chair.

Almost immediately, the phone rang. He glanced at the caller ID. "For god's sake, not *her* again." He resisted the urge to smash his weak elderly fist onto the phone, instead slowly and

deliberately picking it up, as he brushed his hands through his thinning grey hair. In a smooth motion he brought the phone up to his face. "Marie. Always a pleasure to get a call from you."

"Cut the shit, *Nikky*. Have you done it yet?"

Nikolin bit his lip as he fought back a mixture of a small amount of annoyance and a large amount of anger. "...No. She failed again."

"Son of a bitch! Listen here, we pay you *good money* to play around with your pet projects. The only thing we want from you is those mind-interface nanobots, understand? For three billion a year, you're doing very unimpressive work on the taxpayer's dime."

" *US* taxpayer's dime. Not Albania's. Don't act like three billion makes any difference to a government almost fifty trillion in debt. Your new president is signing off on waivers like it's his gift to god. It'd be an over-exaggeration to call it a drop in the bucket." Nikolin felt a small sigh of relief escape his mouth as he enjoyed the momentary relief of telling that bitch off, even if it was a tiny victory.

"You done? I hope that felt real good. Lucky for you, I don't give a rat's ass if you mouth off. I only care about results. You give me those nanobots and you can call me 'queen cunt' if it makes you feel any better. I want *something* by week's end, or *they* are going to pay you a visit, understand?"

Nikolin felt the small feeling of elation from a moment ago drain from his face. "W-what? No... no you can't be serious. It will take at least a few more months! You have to give me more time!"

"Oh, here we go again. It's always 'just around the corner' isn't it, *Nikky*? We give you money, you live it up with croutons and caviar while delivering nothing to me."

"I have the world's most advanced AI. Surely that counts for something?" Nikolin felt the fear from his voice returning a little bit as his hands started slightly trembling.

"AI? Who gives a shit? AI doesn't win votes, it scares the shit out of people. Everyone's seen the movies. HAL isn't going to win the people paying your bills any votes, *Nikky*. But drone soldiers winning the wars for our country? That inspires some patriots to show up at the polls." Marie sighed on the other end of the line, deeply and very audibly. "This is your last chance, 'Doctor'. I'm not giving you another one. Get me the nanobots, *or else*."

Before he could respond, a loud *slam* was heard and the line went dead.

Nikolin slumped in his chair as tears filled his eyes. If *they* came, they'd take him away to one of their black sites. It really was hopeless, the more he thought about it.

Summoning up the best strength he could muster, he stepped outside his lab, walking past a few other researchers and assistants as he returned back to the room with the AI mainframe. Staring up at the hologram of a female face created from scrolling green letters and numbers, he found himself lost in thought, until one of the other researchers walked up to him.

"Doctor Nikolin, are you feeling all right? Your face looks pale."

Nikolin turned around, looking the young woman in the face. "Ah, miss Garret. It's nothing, really. I'm just..." He found his eyes drawn to the floor as many thoughts crossed his mind. "...Do you think the nanobots have a chance? Can we actually make them work?"

Miss Garret pushed her wide framed glasses up her nose. "Of course. It's only a matter of time. We've tested the theories, so now it's all about locating the right genomes, the right neurotransmitters, and once we have those, it'll be a piece of cake."

Nikolin's lip quivered again for a moment before he forced it to stop. "A matter of time... huh? How much time do you expect it would take?"

"Hmm. Well, based on current trends, anywhere from one week to one year. Predictional analysis is not my forte but this particular nanobot issue is so tricky to pin down."

Nikolin felt a wry smile creep onto his mouth. "Yes... so tricky indeed. Tell me, do you suppose we could get it done faster if we connected the AI to the internet?"

Garret's mouth immediately dropped open. "D-doctor Nikolin! That is absolutely not allowable! We must never do that under any circumstance!"

Nikolin quickly let a nervous laugh escape his mouth. "Ah... haha! I'm just kidding, Kimberly. Calm down, it was just a joke!"

She sniffed quickly before quickly turning away. "Yes, a joke. Of course. You're not well known for those you know. Just don't do anything rash. We will solve this problem with hard analytics, as we always have."

Kimberly walked away from him to chat with a coworker as Nikolin stared vacantly ahead where Garret had once been standing. "Yes... just a joke. A ridiculous, unfunny joke."

He slowly turned back to stare at the holographic image in front of him before quietly returning to his work from earlier.

Part 215a:

Uzziel gasped audibly as she saw the incredible sight in front of her. Even Gabriel, shrunken down to a 'normal' sized angelic form, was impressed.

"These are machines for war? How powerful are they?" Gabriel stared in wonder at the varying assortments of robots, auto-piloted armors, and armors that a rider would step into. He recalled something Raphael had told him, many many centuries before, about the power of human innovation.

"I can't really put a number on it, but they're definitely strong enough to win a war. I've filled up five square miles of underground with them, and I'd say we have about 200,000 ready to go. Of course though, that doesn't count the lowest level. Level 11 is where the good stuff goes." I smiled as I walked them towards a rapid-transit elevator I had created using the crown.

To date, I have not displayed my wordsmithing openly to any angel or human. Some may have witnessed me incidentally, but I don't think anyone saw me actually using my abilities yet.

We stepped into the elevator, and in seconds, it had already traveled ten floors underground, each floor being the size of a massive airport hangar, stretching for miles into the distance. Before they could even understand how fast we had traveled in such a short time, we came to a smooth stop at the bottom, as the metal doors hissed open.

Stepping out into the lowest level hangar, I ushered them into the most important room, stifling a grin as they again gasped audibly, this time even more loudly than before.

Spaceships, over a dozen types, were situated on the inside of the room. Using my abilities, I had perfectly remembered every detail of the ship that OMEN was stored in, during the future, and then inspected my own memories of it, allowing me to reverse engineer it with the power of the Crown.

We walked past some small 'fighter' class ships first. A few thousand of them were all over the room. I didn't know how to actually fly them yet, and would likely require an AI or a lot of training to make them work properly, especially for human pilots, but the fact they existed meant we had the possibility of space warfare in the near future.

There were also various types of shuttles, mining ships, and energy-beaming ships that could convert solar and other types of energy into beams of light that could power other ships or stations on the surface of a planet.

"My first goal is to colonize Mars." I stated this simply, leaving the others to roll the thought around in their minds.

"How would you go about doing that? Mars is pretty inhospitable to life, and you don't have nearly enough time to improve it, if what you said about the Volgrim arriving soon is true."

I felt my grin creep out noticeably on my face. "Actually, I'm not worried about time. I can make some pretty magical things happen."

I turned to face Gabriel and Uzziel both. "In fact, this is why I wanted to speak to the two of you today. I need your help. I lack magical energy to accomplish some important tasks in the future. In the timeline I came from, Gabriel, I had a colossal amount of power, similar in vein to your current amount of power, but the amount that I have now is a drop in the bucket compared to it. Might you be able to help me increase my upper limit?"

Gabriel stared ahead at me stonily. "You're asking for a tall task. Understand that we've given you much help, and a lot of aid, all because we simply have to trust in you. But you also are a threat not just to the angels and gods, but humanity and the demons, or rather, life as we know it. Time travel, from the little I know of it, gives you a great power that no others have, which is knowledge of the future. For all I know, you might be manipulating us with that knowledge. Since you seem to be honest, I'm assuming you are not, but please try not to press too hard for more favors."

I nod as I take his words in. "All right... that seems fair enough. I won't bother you about it again."

As we walked along, the two archangels continued to marvel at the varying spaceships as my mind found itself wandering. I need a way to conceal my powers. In the future, I was easily defeated and taken advantage of on multiple occasions because the demons were able to figure out the truths of wordsmithing. Once they understood how it worked, they could protect themselves against my more potent simplistic words, like *die* and *death*.

"By the gods, what is this thing?!" Gabriel gasped in amazement, as did Uzziel. We had finally arrived at the Mothership, my soon-to-be base floating above Earth. It was a massive, jet-shaped spacecraft, sitting almost 5,000 feet long and 2,000 feet wide at its widest points. I wasn't yet sure of how to create FTL drives so we could travel to other stars and star systems, but based on what I had gleaned from OMEN, it was easily possible.

I smiled as I waved my hand dramatically up and towards the spaceship. "This is Mothership Alpha, the first of her kind. She will be my official 'base in space', designed to keep an eye out over the planet, and watch out for a Volgrim incursion. Hopefully, by the time they arrive, we'll

have a fleet in space, waiting for them. I would like to respond with diplomacy, but if they attack first, I will fight back."

"It seems a solid plan. I won't doubt your abilities." Gabriel smiled as he stared up at the amazing spaceship.

After a while, I invited them in, showing off various amenities the ship offered, as well as its more interesting war capabilities and such. A few hours later, Uzziel and Gabriel eventually departed, leaving me to my own thoughts.

* * *

"You know, kid, 'ventually they're gonna figure out what yer abilities are. I can tell yer trying to keep 'em a secret, but secrets erode a friendship." Harold piped in as he seemed to rock back and forth on an invisible chair in my mental vision.

"Yeah, I know. I need to keep my abilities a secret though. It's absolutely essential. I made the mistake of using them too brazenly in the future and it cost me greatly."

Harold nodded. "Well, if that's the case, lemme ask ya some easy questions. First, can you use your wordsmithin' without speaking?"

I shake my head.

"Okay, what 'bout the volume? Does that matter?"

I nod. "The volume affects the intensity of the spell I cast. If I scream something, it's very powerful. If I whisper it, it's very weak."

Harold smiles slightly as his mind ponders things a bit. "A'ight, how 'bout this, why not try wearin' a helmet that's totally soundproof? Then even if ya yell or speak, ain't a soul that kin' hear ya!"

I feel my eyes glaze over. Of course, that makes perfect sense. I doubt such a helmet exists, but I can make it appear easily. Heck, I can make it do all sorts of other things, like reinforce it to the point where a nuclear bomb wouldn't damage it in the slightest. Hell, why not just make a whole new suit of armor? Not to mention the practicality of hiding my aura and disguising my identity.

"Harold, you're a goddamn genius."

Harold leans back and rolls his eyes. "Yeap, I hear ya. Bout time the old folks got a bit o' that recognition 'round here."

I raise my hand up and aim it at a chair nearby. Focusing my mind carefully, I chant a single word. " *Helmet.*"

Part 216a:

Representative Saburo sat atop the highest seat facing the other varying nation members of the new WCN, the Worldwide Cooperative of Nations that had replaced the United Nations from a year before. Ever since the riots and uprisings around the world in the previous year, several key figureheads of the world's top leaders, senators, and other representatives had been locked up or killed in the streets, with the people instituting their own leaders who were now seated around the large theater, speaking quietly to their nearby seated neighbors on issues of varying importance.

Saburo was the representative for Egypt, an otherwise mostly neutral nation who had already had their previous dictator killed in the early 2010's. However, in 2019, it was now a prosperous nation with a rapidly building military, a strong agriculture, and strong borders. Due to its neutrality, the representative of Egypt was chosen to lead the Worldwide Cooperative of Nations on matters of public interest around the world.

"Order. A call to order, please." Saburo smacked his gavel down as the loud whispering and chattering quieted down around the room. He stroked his youthful chin quietly with his left hand as he picked up a small set of papers with his right. "We will now bring the 24th weekly meeting of the WCN to its beginning. Member nations, we have some important matters to attend to on matters of trade. I've heard that the former world power, the USA, has been exercising a bit too much force against their trading partner, Russia."

The new prime minister of Russia spoke up, his voice being translated in real time to text on screens in front of all the other delegates in their native language. All languages were cross translated in real time now, allowing for ease of speaking, though errors and miscommunications did still happen as machines were not perfect at conveying nuances of human speech, at least for now.

"The new president has been very impolite in how he deals with my country. I am not fond of the way he treats us, and I think he had better apologize to us if he wishes to continue with the free trade deal we agreed upon." Prime Minister Victor Sokolov glared across the room at the new president of the USA, Steven Johannesburg, who had won the hastily put-together election campaign of 2018 with only 36% of the vote after the riots of the two previous years had calmed down and the citizens hungered for a new leader to replace the previous one.

Steven coughed as he shuffled some notes on his desk. Widely seen as a weak and ineffective leader since his inauguration, he was more adept at economic strategies and public speeches

than he was at trade negotiations and matters of war. "Minister Sokolov, these allegations are false. A submarine wandered into your waters, and we quickly pulled them out of the way. We were not attempting to harass you, and I most certainly apologize for any, erm, any accidental provocation it may have seemed like. It was certainly not my inten-..."

Victor cut him off. "Nonsense! When all the people of the nations are looking down on you in this room, you act as though it was an accident, but you and I both know that submarine was there to cause an international incident! You still think your nation can get away with provoking other countries to war, yet you forget how far and how quickly you've fallen!"

Steven wiped his brow with the back of his hand. *Damn, it's hot as hell in here. God, I hope it isn't just me.* He silently thought this to himself, as the hundred plus eyes in the room bore down on him. Seated at the front of the room, at the bottom of the amphitheater with the other first world countries, it was easy to feel their eyes boring into his back. "L-like I said, I've apologized, and it won't happen again. What more can I do to put you at ease?"

Minister Sokolov merely glared at him for a few moments before looking away. "Very well. Make sure it does not happen again. In front of all these member nations, I'm warning you now to keep out of Russian waters."

Representative Saburo swallowed quietly as he watched the minor spat break out. Nuclear proliferation hadn't quite been reduced since the last two years of riots, and the possibility of WWIII was always on the horizon.

"Now that we've gotten that out of the way, let's move on the the next, ah, order of business." Saburo reached for a paper in front of himself titled "Resolving the remaining conflicts in the Middle East", but as he reached for it, there was a sudden massive flash of light in the middle of the room, instantly blinding everyone, as if someone had thrown a flash-bang grenade.

Saburo yelped in surprise, as did many others. For a few moments, there was chaos as people screamed in pain. Finally, as people blinked back tears and whipped their heads all over the room, searching for the source of the light, they all quickly fixated their attention on something baffling that they had never seen before.

In the middle of the room, hovering in midair, as if he were Superman or something, a man adorned all in white levitated silently. He wore a pure white helmet that covered his entire head, some sort of pure white body armor that appeared to be like a body suit, had white boots and silken white gloves, and wore a white cape. Across the front of his shirt, in gold, there was the image of an eagle screaming with its wings outspread dramatically. Saburo at first did not see the front of the man, as his front was aimed at the delegates in the auditorium, but when he

glanced over at the TV monitor showing him hovering mere feet from the Head Stand that Saburo sat at, it was impossible to miss.

The man's helmet slid to the side, revealing just his mouth and chin. His arms crossed, the man spoke in an impossibly loud booming voice, as if he had somehow amplified his ability to speak to levels similar to that of a PA system.

"Citizens of the world, leaders of all countries on this planet, and honored delegates. I am a time traveler from the distant future. My name is not important, but you may call me the *Judicator*. I have come back in time to deliver justice on behalf of the human race, in an effort to prevent our near-total extermination. Whether or not you choose to believe me is up to you."

The man's opening statement caused dozens of jaws to noticeably slacken and mouths to slightly open. *Who the hell was this guy?*

Part 217a:

Amy sat on the couch watching her favorite TV show, Dora the Explorer. As she watched Dora going on an adventure, she wobbled her legs back and forth, trying to touch the floor.

While she watched, the TV suddenly changed to a different channel, something about an open room filled with lots of people. "Mommy! The cartoons went away! Mommy!"

Her mother, Laura Sandoval, walked around the corner slowly, glancing down at her smartphone in confusion. It had just changed from a mobile game app she was playing to a streaming video of a large conference of some sort. The TV had changed channel as well, and the radio in the kitchen, usually playing Pop Songs on KTZL 104.5FM, was now playing the exact same conference over the radio.

"I'm not sure why it's doing that." Laura said, as she pressed the channel and volume buttons on the TV. The remote seemed to have no effect and she had thought it was dead, but the TV itself seemed to not be responding.

While she fiddled with the buttons, a sudden blast of light appeared on the screen, making her hop back in surprise.

Onscreen, a man dressed all in white appeared as she and billions of other people around the world leaned in to stare at their devices in confusion.

* * *

"Whether we choose to believe you? Why are you here? This is ridiculous." Saburo felt almost annoyed at the sudden appearance of the stranger, though his heart was beating fast. *Shit, what if this guy is a terrorist? He could kill over a hundred major world leaders in seconds. How did he get in here anyway, this is supposed to be more secure than Guantanamo Bay.*

As he asked the question, security from the place immediately rushed up to the stranger floating in the air. As they whipped out their pistols to aim at him, his visor on his face closed, and a moment later, every single guard in the room fell over and slumped to the ground. *Holy shit, did he just kill them all?!*

"Everyone, I want you all to remain seated and calm." The man's mouth visor was already open again. It opened and closed so rapidly and silently you might even miss it if you weren't paying attention. "Let me first say that I mean you no harm. I am not here to set off a bomb, kill,

or maim anyone. Those guards are merely unconscious. However, if anyone takes lethal action against me, I will retaliate in kind. *Do I make myself clear?* "

His booming, masculine voice bounced around the room. People in the audience were visibly shaking, some were swallowing hard as they stared in mute terror.

"...Excellent. I see I've gotten your attention. I thought this would be the best way to make my presence known to the world, and especially the leaders of the world."

"W-who are you? Why are you here?" The president of the United States, Steven Johannesburg, felt himself shaking visibly as he stared up at the potential terrorist, but the situation seemed precarious and he dared not say a word to make the man do anything rash.

"Like I already said, I am the Judicator. I'm a time traveler from a hundred million years in the future. I have come to warn humanity of an existential threat on the horizon. Something that will bring about an end to all life as we know it. A threat so grim that even-" The masked man tilted his head slightly at the president, a knowing nod of sorts. "-even the Penitas Research doesn't hold a candle to its danger."

Steven's expression instantly hardened. *Who the fuck is this son of a bitch? That's beyond the highest top secret clearance level knowledge.* "How do you know about-" Stevens caught himself. If he mentioned it here, and a smart world leader caught wind, it could blow the whole lid off their existence. "...Fine. I understand that you definitely aren't playing around. Do you have any demands?"

Minister Sokolov watched with fascination. *The president seems to be shifting uncomfortably. I might be able to make good use of this stranger in a more private setting. He seems to know something important.*

"I have no demands. I'm here to give a warning, and offer a call to action. Humanity needs to end all of its petty wars with its own species. No more fighting amongst ourselves, period. We need to join hands with... the *others* and cooperate in order to defeat the external threat, if things should turn violent."

Sokolov interjected, tossing himself into the conversation. Speaking politely, he stared directly at the eye-plate of the helmet that the masked man wore. "Mister Judicator, you seem to be a man of much influence here, yet you are being very vague. What is this threat that we face? What is this threat that would make a flying man who can knock out a dozen men with guns in a single moment nervous?"

'Judicator' paused for a moment as he thought about it. "This will, almost invariably, sound preposterous, but I assure you it is the truth. Earth will soon, in the near future, come under

attack by aliens. By the end of the 24th century, they will somehow, possibly, manage to wipe out all life on the planet."

Instantly, the crowd that was once frozen in terror broke the silence as people quickly began muttering among each other about this and that.

"Aliens? Well... you had me until that." Stevens leaned back in his chair. Despite his words, he was wondering if there wasn't a grain of truth to it. Every supposed UFO rumor from the 50's was totally false, and every president was able to see the black sites for themselves, along with Area 51 and all those other supposed alien landing sites. It was all false, every last bit of it, as far as he knew. Yet this visitor displayed extraordinary powers, right along the same power type that the secret allies of the USA also had, as well as their enemies.

Only the USA knew about the existence of angels and demons, and even then it was only a handful of extremely high ranking government personnel, and of course the billionaires who truly ran the country, along with the rest of the world.

One of the things that had mystified the world for over a century was why the USA was so damn dogged in its defense of religious liberty, and why so many Americans *swore* they had seen angels. To be fair, most of those rumors were totally true. It was documented in secret books of past societies that certain influential humans of the past had been classified as 'heroes' possessing extraordinary powers and abilities.

And when he thought about it, Stevens kept thinking to himself that this man floating in the air had a high probability of being a Type 3 energy candidate. If that were the case, the chances he was evil or trying to harm humanity was extremely low. He *might* be a demon, but if that were the case he'd have likely taken the opportunity to kill everyone here, or mind control them all, or something like that.

The man floating in the air shrugged. "I don't expect the leaders of the world to believe me immediately, but you had better believe this: I have created a massive armada that is ready to defend Earth. I need volunteers, men or women, I care not, to pilot them and protect the planet. The reason I have come here today is to gauge interest in protecting this planet. If you will offer up a portion of your military strength, as a truly united front for humanity, we can change the future. We can prevent the total and complete destruction of our homeworld."

The man's visor closed once again, as a series of holographic images floated in the air all around him. Various mecha fighting robots, spaceships of varying sorts, and images of his massive hangar came into view. Audible gasps and sharp intaking of air were heard, as people in the room beheld the multiple marvels he put on display.

Saburo watched silently from the rear, as all of this happened. *Whoever this man is, he seems to have convinced the United States that he's for real, and this holographic stuff is extremely convincing. He must be serious.* Saburo leaned forwards as he rested his chin on his splayed out hands.

Sokolov stared intently at the holographic images, and decided to pounce. He was not a man to wait around quietly and think. "Mister Judicator! I accept your generous offer! On behalf of the proud nation of Russia, I offer twenty percent of my country's troops! May you find favor with them, and be inclined to remember this gift in future deals."

Stevens stuffed down a glare he felt like shooting at Sokolov. *This is the worst case scenario. I can't let the Russians get ahold of any of this top secret information.* "Judicator, I too believe you will be a great *hero* to humanity. I will pledge 20% of the United States' troops to the cause as well." He put emphasis on the word Hero, and noted that Judicator's head wobbled slightly. *Good, he noticed.*

Other nations stepped up to bat, metaphorically speaking. By the end of that first hour, over twenty million troops were pledged to fight the alien threat.

* * *

Laura stared at the TV vacantly. *Aliens? He can't be serious. But all of my devices tuned in to C-SPAN at the same time, that wasn't a coincidence. And the Russian Prime Minister along with our own president believed him. He must be for real.*

Amy cheerfully hopped up and down. "Aliens are coming! Aliens are coming! That's so cool! I'm gonna fight them when I grow up!"

Laura nodded slowly, as she forced a smile for her daughter's sake, pushing back tears of fear so her daughter wouldn't notice. "Yes, baby girl. The aliens... are coming..."

Laura didn't sleep that night. Neither did billions of other people.

Part 218a:

Aboard the Dolfraxis, energy was high as the crew felt the anticipation of arriving in a new star system. For thousands of years, they had traveled in search of planets in the habitable zone of varying stars, but all had turned up empty.

Still, it was normal to feel a sense of hope as they approached each new star system. While inevitable disappointment would likely be felt, it still took a backseat to speculation, at least for now.

"Helmsman, reduce speed from Warp 2 to half-light-speed when we're within 100,000 Light-Units from the habitable zone of the star." Elder Nufaris spoke calmly as the initial scans came in.

"Time to arrival is... 0.1 standard rotational units." Ichus 04, a senior staff member on board the star-ship, one who manned the scanning array, indicated the display as he tapped an indicator on his screen. "Dropping to half-light-speed in five... four... three... two... one..."

A barely noticeable deceleration was felt as the warp drive's power was sharply cut, the sublight engines taking over. All around them, the blackness seemed to shift imperceptibly as the star in this system came into focus.

"Running a full scan of the system now. 14 planetoids detected, along with over a hundred moons....Very promising. Three planets are in the habitable zone, though none of them are in the ideal range, there might be a miracle." Primus 16 read off the results of the scan to Elder Nufaris as they came in. As an assistant, he was extremely good at his job, though that was to be expected given the specialized DNA he had been created with.

Elder Nufaris stared unblinkingly as the results appeared on his screen. "Hmm. Give me a full readout on the fourth planetoid, the one just before the asteroid belt."

"Understood. It appears to be a dead planet, though we'll know when we get closer. I'm detecting high concentrations of bacterial and microbial life, though much of it appears to be dead. In fact-"

Before he could finish, a Volgrim on the other side of the bridge screeched in excitement. "ELDER! By the founders, I'm detecting something! T-the third planetoid!!" Kelfarim 19, another young Volgrim, hopped in his seat excitedly as all eyes on the bridge jerked towards him. "P-primitive radio-based transmissions! I'm detecting movement in the orbit of the planet as well! I think it might be life!"

Nufaris felt his internal organs flip-flopping, both in excitement, hope, and fear. If this truly was life, he couldn't believe his fortune, but he had to be wary. "Kelfarim, give me a full detailed readout on that planetoid. I want details. Ichus, you as well."

"Yes, elder!" Both of them chirped excitedly, hardly able to believe their luck. Of all the thousands or millions of ships searching for life, they were the first ones to find it! And considering the state of Volgarius that they had last heard from dozens of orbits ago, they were in need of a new homeworld, badly.

"Elder, the planet seems to be extremely primitive in nature. I'm detecting billions upon billions of forms of life living there, in addition to primitive brick, stone, and metal structures littering the surface." Kelfarim rapped over buttons faster than his eyes might seem to move.

"Elder Nufaris, I've finished decoding the types of radio transmissions they are sending out. Take a look onscreen." Ichus slapped a button as the viewscreen came alive. A grainy video appeared, with lines scrolling through it periodically. In the video, a battle raged between two bipedal aliens, holding devices in their hands. The devices had long, plasma-like blades that sprouted from the bottom, seeming to hum as if they were alive. As the two bipeds swung their weapons at each other, the weapons seemed alive, able to cut through any type of surface they came into contact with. Nufaris narrowed his eyes as he watched the prowess of two battle hardened warriors. They appeared to speak to each other, but the universal translator yet lacked the information needed to roughly translate anything.

"I have another signal." Ichus pressed a button, as the grim battle scene in a fiery volcano vanished, and another one appeared. A voice appeared to be speaking about something in a dark tone. As he spoke, a vehicle of some sort, appearing to drive on circular wheels (very primitive, Nufaris thought to himself) drove at a high speed away from some sort of primitive city. What happened next though made everyone on the bridge recoil in horror, as a massive explosion, colossal in size, exploded and destroyed the entire city. Bipedal life forms of some sort were destroyed instantly, their bodies evaporated into the wind, as the blast seared through their bodies. Moments later, a scene of violent looking death robots appeared, marching forwards as if to terrorize the other life on the planet, their fiery red eyes and metallic skin putting great fear in the hearts of all on board the Dolfraxis.

Elder Nufaris felt himself blanch as he witnessed the horror onscreen.

"Elder, the AI has managed to decode most of their language. It appears to be similar in form to ancient forms of language our own people used to use. The syntax is different as are the conjugations and adjectives, but the computer can translate it to a mostly fluent form of our own language." Primus 16 held his finger over the button on his datapad, waiting for the OK.

Strange. An alien planet millions, if not billions of light years from our own. It has a language similar to ours? Life works in mysterious ways. Elder Nufaris found himself thinking odd thoughts as he stared at the bipedal life-forms on his screen. *Their forms are similar to our own. What is this planet?*

"Put it on screen, Primus. Let us hear what they have to say."

Primus pressed the button as another video played. A male voice appeared to be speaking over a video of war. "World War Two was the deadliest war in our history. An estimated Eighty Million people died worldwide, as a result not just of bombings, lynchings, gunfire, artillery, and other such weapons of war, but also due to disease and famine, along with the Nazi and Russian death camps. Global relations have improved greatly in these last 80 years, but another world war is always lurking on the horizon, as long as nuclear weapons are in play."

As the male voice spoke, another dramatic image of a fantastic explosion played on screen. An entire city, again wiped out by a massive thermal detonation. After that, yet another explosion played, showing a totally different city being destroyed. "Nuclear weapons chilled the world to the bone, as people finally understood where humanity was headed. Fearing for the end of our kind, world leaders began to embrace the idea of Mutually Assured Destruction, that is to say, if one side attacks another with a nuclear weapon, the other side would retaliate, and both would be the loser for it. As a result, there have been no more nuclear attacks in the decades since then."

Nufaris felt his entire body turn to ice as he watched the footage. "Barbaric. This is truly a warlike species. Ichus 04, take us to stand-still speed. I want to examine this planet very, very carefully before we proceed. Also, Kelfarim, send a single shuttle back to Volgarius. Warp 8, push the speed to the utmost level. We can't take the time to send a sub-space message, it will take too long. Download all information on this star system. We need to be sure the homeworld knows of their existence."

"Yes, Elder. I contemplate, and I comprehend." Both of the bridge members leaped into action just as their commanding officer ordered.

"For now, we will stay here and... *observe*."

Part 219a:

Everything is going so well now.

The first batch of ten thousand recruits have arrived in my 'secret' base, which is not only no longer secret, it's now classified as a sovereign territory outside all existing country laws, so that the USA can't attempt to seize my technology, tax me, etc.

No reverse engineering is allowed either. All people sent to work here under me must do as I say, when I say it. It's like being a dictator, except the goal is planetary defense and it's for the good of all humanity.

The day has only just begun, yet most of the new recruits are already practicing and learning how to pilot these mecha and spaceships. There have been a few accidents, one of which was quite serious, but the loss of a bad pilot or two doesn't bother me, and I can just clone a mecha or a spaceship if need be.

The only thing nobody is allowed to touch for now is the Mothership itself. I'm currently keeping it as totally restricted access. I could probably clone it, but it's massive and extremely intricate, so to do so would cost me a massive amount of energy. As such, I'm mostly focusing on the smaller fighters.

Leaving behind the crowd of people, as I delegate leaders and various groups to run things for a while, I head into the mothership, noting the lights are all on and the soft, barely perceivable humming of the engine is purring in the background.

"Harold, how are you holding up?" I slide my helmet's mouth cover open as I step onto the bridge and the viewscreen flicks on, and a holographic representation of Harold's face is displayed onscreen.

"Aw, shucks. Well, I'm doin' pretty fine, I guess. It's a bit weird bein' all hooked up to them space 'puters 'n stuff, but it could be worse. Surprisin'ly it's a lot easier ta get used to than I expected."

Using a system I had created myself, I've now put Harold deep inside the ship's core, in a secure locked room where nobody other than me knows his location. Using a special spiritual link, I attached him to the ship's AI, allowing him to be a sort of pseudo-AI that can control everything on-board all at once.

An interesting part of being locked inside the Beacon of Life, as the angels call it, is that he really isn't a human anymore, nor does he have human limits. He still thinks like one, he still

thinks of himself *as* a human, but in the end he is not a human anymore. He has enhanced perception abilities, clear thinking totally unlike before he had died and when he suffered from Alzheimer Disease, and with this new invention of mine it appears he can split himself into several thousand mechanical functions at once.

I'm beginning to wonder if I'll actually need a full crew complement at all or if I should just majorly expand the hangar bays instead.

I've made many automatons on the ship too, which for now serve as the crew manifest. Harold controls all of them. It's kind of amusing to see a big tough robot speaking in a southerner accent.

"Harold, are we about ready to lift off? Today is the day we're supposed to enter Earth's orbit."

"Yeap, I'd say we're ready. But 'fore we do that, you got a message waitin'!"

"A message? Who is it from?" I narrow my eyes as I stare at his face on the screen.

"He says he's one o' them demons you told me about. Calls himself 'Satan', like the name of the actual devil! He sent me a message with a location for you to go to. I dunno if I'd trust him though..."

"Well, obviously one does not simply trust another named after the most vile demon in the bible, but I'm... acquainted with him."

Thoughts roll through my mind. Satan wishes to speak with me? Are he and I not mortal enemies? Even if he doesn't know who I am as he was not in the future, he must surely know I am a Hero, and thusly we should not be speaking.

To be honest though, I really know nothing about him. I only know what Samantha told me when she'd get all starry eyed, and I know of him personally only from our one fight where he defeated me easily. In fact, I'm roughly as powerful now as I was back then, so I assume I'd get defeated again easily if he decided to go on the offensive.

...Or would I? One of the reasons I couldn't beat him was that Amelia had been the first person to protect herself against my wordsmithing, and thusly her puppets as well. But since Amelia doesn't know who I am now, and since Satan isn't her puppet, perhaps a simple 'die' command would instantly kill him? I still have the upper hand so far in that nobody yet knows exactly what my powers are.

I should go out to meet him, soon.

But for now, this is the official launch day. "Harold, I'll ignore that request for now. Today we need to enter orbit so we have a preliminary defense against the Volgrim in case they arrive

with hostile intentions."

"Aight, whatever you says, boss. I'm jes' an old man, what do I even know? Dumb ol' stupid ol' man." Harold delivered a harsh critique of himself as he went back to mumbling. Outside the ship, I observed through the screens installed in my helmet and the various useful sensors that the starting thrusters had already been ignited. I guess Harold was more prepared than I gave him credit for.

My helmet and suit are really quite remarkable. They harness my own large amount of spiritual energy to power the various systems inside them, and they possess many systems as a whole. The helmet has a bunch of visual and tactical displays that use radar, infrared, and many other systems to see what's going on around me in a 360-degree view. To be honest, it's like an inferior version of my spatial vision, but I'm keeping that off right now so I can't be detected as a generic Hero by any schlub with a Type 3 Energy Scanner.

There's also an earpiece that allows me to hear things going on around me with pinpoint precision, allowing me to zoom in and hear things through walls if I need to, or hear the sound of a fly buzzing around ten miles away.

My suit also is heavily reinforced, to the point where a nuclear bomb, gamma radiation, basically nothing can penetrate it. It has impact dampeners so that if I get punched into the ground at the speed of sound, it will absorb much of the impact. It also totally muffled my movement when I walk around. I'm absolutely silent all the time, which has led to some awkward encounters.

As I observe the viewfinder at the ship's helm, the engines fire up and the massive hangar door opens, sliding open on the left and right side. It takes nearly ten minutes for the entire thing to fully open, but once it does, the ship is finally able to take itself and liftoff. Of course, I could just teleport myself and the Mothership into space, but this is so much more fun! Well, that and the fact that I probably would die if I tried such a thing.

The ship ignites the liftoff thrusters after the entire hangar has cleared out, people lining the far right and left walls, cheering as they watch Earth's foremost protector slowly glide out of the hangar using anti-gravity engine.

The massive ship eases itself forwards, slowly at first, then faster and faster until it has finally cleared the hangar bay ceiling and doors. Sitting at four stories tall, it is not a small ship by any means.

Once we're flying in the first thousand feet in the air, Harold speaks enthusiastically. "No airplanes or none o' them flyin' around! Yeehaw!"

With that, he ignites the main thruster, and the ship blasts forwards with unbelievable speed. Were it not for the insane gravity dampeners on-board the ship, I would have been hit with at least ten G's, and possibly quite a lot more, standing on board the bridge with nothing to hold on to.

After less than two minutes of rapid flight, we've cleared the upper atmosphere and are flying in the black void of space.

I look around me. The sky is dark, yet filled with thousands, tens of thousands, even millions of visible stars. This is not like being on Earth... you can see every dot in the sky with pristine quality.

The universe is vast, yet 99% of the stars I see with my naked eye are just those within the Milky Way. It's impossible for my human mind to comprehend the vastness of space... some say that if you visited one star, every second, with the goal of visiting every star in just our galaxy, it would take you 126 years to visit all the stars in just our galaxy. Combined with the stars in all the other galaxies? The numbers become mind boggling.

The moon is incredibly big, now that I've escaped the light bending properties of Earth's atmosphere. The sun is unbelievably bright as well, to the point where my helmet had to auto-dim the screen I looked at so I wasn't blinded. In fact-

My thoughts are interrupted by Harold. "Uhh, Jason? I can see another spaceship. It's just 'fore the asteroid belt. You might wanna take a look at this."

What?! Another spaceship, that can only mean- "It has to be the Volgrim. Scan it immediately."

Part 220a:

"We've received a communication from Volgarius, direct from the Founders themselves." Primus 16 glanced at the symbols scrolling across his datapad as he read the message title. "URGENT: Must read immediately."

"That was remarkably fast. How were they able to transmit a message within a tenth of an orbital cycle?" Elder Nufaris stared ahead at the vast emptiness of space as he folded his arms behind his back.

"I'm not sure. Perhaps new technology? We've been gone a great many orbits, you know." Primus 16 almost felt silly, reminding the Elder of such a normal thing. Of *course* he knew how long they'd been gone. He knew better than anyone.

The Elder graciously ignored what other elders might consider a grievous slight. "Hmm, yes, indeed. Still, I thought we had reached the limits of space travel, yet they're still finding new ways to innovate. Read me the message."

Primus 16 nodded as he pressed the command to open it. Usually a direct message to the Elder would only be readable by the Elder, but since he gave the order in front of the entire crew, their AI allowed it this time.

Primus started to read, but before he could speak the first words, his voice caught as his eyes read faster than his lips could speak. "E-Elder. I do not believe I should read this aloud."

Nufaris glanced back at him. "Hmm? Give it here." He took the datapad from Primus 16 and read the message contents silently.

Immediately leave Sector 16 space. Do not return. Do not engage. Do not contact the primitives. Failure to comply will result in immediate court martial.

The message was simple and short. Just a single paragraph. No explanations of any sort. Nufaris glared down at the datapad in his hands. Of course he would comply, but this wording... what made the Founders themselves send a message with such urgent contents? It was almost as if they were hiding something.

Nufaris raised his eyes up from the datapad, as he stared through the diamond-like plexiglass at the Void outside his ship. Hundreds of billions of stars. and he had stumbled upon the only other known one with life on it, and now the Founders would surely take credit for it. What was a lowly Elder to do but comply. Were it just himself, he might act against it, but putting the lives of his crew at risk was non-negotiable.

How he longed for the days of his youth, when he was scolded by his teachers and the ones who formed him from the maturation chambers.

Nufaris sighed deeply, a sigh filled with thousands of years of anguish. After all his time searching, he'd finally found a tiny blue ball, shrouded in the blackness of space, filled with terrifyingly violent barbarian natives. While primitive, they reminded him of the Past Ages, stories he had heard when he was but a youth on his planet, merely a few hundred orbits old. The Volgrim had once been barbaric and ruthless in their own ways, and had eventually entered the age of enlightenment, allowing them to move past petty disputes, for the good of their civilization.

Naturally, they still possessed fantastic weapons of war, old automatons left over from the Final War tens of thousands of years ago, but as of now, those old relics were left in ancient museums to collect dust.

Staring out the window at the blue dot, far into the distance, Nufaris felt a tinge of regret. He should very much have liked to be the one to initiate first contact with these primitives. Perhaps he might have gained insight into how his own people had evolved into the enlightened state they were in now.

Nufaris felt his sigh fade into the air around him as he turned to his helmsman. "Ichus, set course, warp 6. Return us to Volgarius."

Ichus turned around, his face filled with dismay. "We're... returning home?"

"Yes, Ichus. We do not question the orders of Volgarius, especially when they come from the Founders themselves."

"O-of course, Elder. My apologies." Ichus turned around, quickly pressing some buttons on his console.

The ship slowly turned around, deliberately, as if it were desperately fighting itself to leave. Indeed, even their own ship seemed to not wish to leave this place behind.

At that moment, Kelfarim 19, the bridge member in charge of the scanning crew, jerked back from his seat. "E-elder! A ship! That planetoid suddenly had a new spaceship fly into its orbit. It looks highly advanced! I-it's scanning us with a long range scanner not unlike ours!"

Nufaris felt his blood chill to absolute zero as he whipped his head around to look at the scanning image on the viewscreen. This far from the third planet, almost at the edge of the asteroid belt, they couldn't get a clear image of it, but their scans indicated it was a *massive* ship. Easily ten times the size of their own.

"Report. Give me details on it."

"Right, Elder. It has a- by the founders! It wields a massive arsenal of weapons! Primitive nuclear torpedo launchers, advanced plasma cannons, photon phasers, and possibly gravity bombs too! At least three hundred weapons on the firing side, and another hundred or so on the rear side."

Ichus was doing his own examination of the data. "Their scanner is at least as advanced as ours! They have tactical data on our capabilities!"

Nufaris blanched. His ship was a scouting ship. It had no weaponry in the slightest. If that monstrosity attacked them, they would be shredded in seconds. "Ichus! Get back to work! Get us out of here, now!"

As he spoke, the AI on board their ship suddenly activated an alarm. "RED ALERT. RED ALERT. INTRUDER DETECTED ONBOARD THE DOLFRAXIS. INTRUDER LOCATED IN BRIDGE SECTION 001. RED ALERT."

The bridge?! That meant-! Nufaris jerked his head back around to see a single bipedal life-form standing on board their bridge. None of its body was visible, as it wore a suit colored pure white, with a strange golden symbol of some animal native to their planet across the front. The being wore a helmet, likely to disguise his identity.

"The intruder-!" Ichus reared back in fright, as did the other staff on the bridge. The intruder raised a single five fingered hand up at the Elder, as the lower half of his helmet slid open, revealing a mouth and chin. He spoke, in perfect Volgarian.

"Hold. I mean you no harm."

Part 221a:

Stepping onto the transporter on-board my Mothership, in the blink of an eye, Harold sent me over to the bridge of the Volgrim ship.

The instant I arrived, alarm bells went off all over the ship. I couldn't understand anything at first, but by quickly casting " *Understand* ." followed by " *Translate* ." I was able to get the gist of what was being said by their computer. It was apparently an intruder alert of some sort.

My helmet's mouthpiece slid open as I held my hand up to speak to the crew. "Hold. I mean you no harm."

Many thoughts rushed into my head. First, the Volgrim themselves. I don't know what I was expecting, but they looked like vicious monsters. They appeared to look like humans, but there were many important differences, not least of which was that each one had a mouth filled to the brim with hundreds of razor-sharp teeth. As for their height, they each stood at least six feet tall, with the leader being nearly 8 feet tall. They towered over me, and I suddenly had a horrible feeling that by coming here directly I had made a horrible mistake.

Their huge forms, coupled with their shark-like teeth and their nearly-pitch black eyes made them look far more fearsome than any demon I had ever seen, but I kept my nerves tight as I spoke.

The leader of their group, one tall son-of-a-bitch, turned to speak to me in a horrible deep rasping voice, like the sound a wolf might make as it swallows a huge hunk of meat. "Human! How did you get on board our ship?"

"I teleported here using my ship's technology. Why are you in our planetary space?" I didn't intend to ask such an aggressive question, but these terrifying looking aliens were the stuff of nightmares. They were the exact definition of the 'uncanny valley'.

A smaller one stepped in front of the leader, hissing as he moved. "We came to investigate this planet to see if it had any life. Lower your weapon or we will use force against you."

I felt my eyebrow raise. My weapon? I only had my hand up. Did they think I had a weapon concealed? I quickly lowered my hand as I took stock of the bridge crew. Only 5 fearsome looking aliens here. I'm pretty sure if need be, I'd win in a fist-fight, no matter how tough they looked. My suit was extremely enhanced.

"I'm not here to fight, I just want to talk. I've been expecting you."

The leader of the aliens stared down at me. "I am Elder Nufaris, the one who commands this ship. Explain yourself. How could you be *expecting* us? We've been inside this star system for many cycles now and your planet showed no signs of noticing our presence."

I grimace. Shit, I didn't mean to say that. Oh well, roll with it. "I am one of the most powerful of the humans on my planet. I have access to knowledge that every other one does not possess. You may call me-" I paused because my stand-in name did not translate into their language. 'Judicator' was out of the question. "-...You may call me Justice-Seeker."

The tallest alien, Nufaris, narrowed his eyes. "Justice-Seeker, hmm? And what injustice might you be seeking to right? Have we harmed your planet in some way?"

I don't see a way to answer this without admitting I'm a time traveler. I've really stepped my foot in it. Perhaps I should just redirect the question. "More importantly, why are you staying out here and observing my planet? What could your motives be?"

The tall alien started to respond, but the smaller one in front of him nudged him. "Elder... the founder's orders..."

The Elder alien stopped narrowing his eyes a bit and returned to a more normal, fearsome monstrous expression. "I'm beginning to understand, I believe. Your planet is clearly more advanced than it appears, perhaps a ruse in case of an attack by foreign species? I've seen evidence of your barbarism by the signals you are broadcasting to the void."

The void? What is he talking about? Perhaps he is referring to outer space... there's definitely a language barrier here, even with my ability to translate instantly. "Humanity is indeed somewhat violent, but I'm only here to talk, not to cause a situation."

"Perhaps that is true! But if that were the case, why not hail us with your ship and ask permission to come aboard? Do your people lack self-awareness of their actions?"

I shook my head quickly, a millisecond later realizing that my human gestures might be totally foreign to them. "I simply am not aware of your protocols. On my planet, we would, ah, simply show up unannounced! It's our form of a greeting, a *friendly* greeting." I try and roll a bit of a smile into my mouth but it might come off insincere. Not to mention that to some animals, baring your teeth could be a sign of aggression. I need to be careful with my body language.

"Hmm, this one seems to conceal his head. Why might that be?" The small one in front of the elder seemed to hiss under his breath, but everyone could plainly hear him.

I paused for a nanosecond before quickly opening up my helm. "My apologies, I've been so impolite! I came aboard your ship without regard to how you might perceive my actions, and so

far I've been quick to conceal my intentions. Perhaps we've started off on the wrong foot?"

One of the bridge crew glanced over at another, before asking a quick question. "What does this one mean, talking about feet? What do feet have to do with anything?"

The other responded back quietly. "The humans are crafty, they speak in a way that hides their true intentions."

Ugh, these aliens don't understand euphemisms, figures of speech, body language, general customs, or much of anything. This is surprisingly tough to negotiate anything diplomatically with them. "Alright, let me be serious for a moment. I have a way to see into the future. I can predict great fortunes and misfortunes. As such, I was able to predict the monumental impact of a first contact with an alien species. As such, I've quietly been preparing to meet with the visitors for a few years now. Does that satisfy your curiosity?"

The elder stared me up and down for a few moments. "Hmm, it seems you are not lying." His foul voice, the sound of a bear howling while swallowing a rabbit whole, made his words very unpleasant to listen to. "However, we simply do not know if we can trust you. We must return to our people in order to discuss future relations with your world and how we should proceed."

A bit of panic crept into the back of my mind. This was just a scouting ship. What if they sent back word of how primitive and weak our planet was, and returned with an armada of ships? They could possibly commit genocide on my planet hundreds of years early!

...But then again, what if they are actually peaceful? Their appearance is beyond frightening, but perhaps I've been too quick to judge them. "Elder Volgrim, if you return to your planet, do I have your word you will not return to attack mine? I should very much prefer peaceful relations, if at all possible."

The elder narrowed his eyes again as he looked at me. "Volgrim? How do you know the name of my species as well? You seem to know much information for only having scanned us a few moments before arriving on board our ship... nevertheless, even if I wanted to, I could promise no such thing. If the Founders were to declare war on your planet it would be outside my jurisdiction. That being said, I would take your request into account to try and sway them towards peace."

I stifled a grimace. That was... likely the best I'd be getting. And once again, I had let information slip that I shouldn't have. "Very well. I will have to accept it. Know this though, if your people return with the intent to wage war, I can guarantee they will not win easily, if at all. Humanity is a fearsome force once mobilized against a common threat. You would do well to pursue peaceful relations with our planet."

The elder nodded sagely as he dipped his eyes shut for a moment. "We will return, human. I contemplate, and I comprehend."

His final words seemed like a farewell of some sort, so I returned it in kind. "I also contemplate and comprehend. Farewell, elder Nufaris."

With that, my helmet snapped shut, and I quickly spoke the " *Recall* ." word in order to return to my ship.

Teleporting back inside my ship, I watched with a mixture of relief and apprehension as their ship turned away on my scanner view and warped out a minute later.

Harold spoke quietly. "Got dayum... them aliens are worse 'n I expected..."

He had seen what I had seen. "I know."

* * *

Elder Nufaris watched as the 'human' left in the blink of an eye. Teleporting himself with such speed, and with no visible commands... this one was not one to be trifled with.

"He lied, Elder." Primus 16 glared at the ship shown on the viewfinder, as the Dolfraxis turned around and powered up its warp engines.

"Of course he did. The human was no fool at first, he even imbued mind-reading blockers into that helmet, but he was stupid enough to remove it."

"It all evens out." Primus stared at the viewscreen as the warp engine activated. In the blink of an eye, a tiny bit of inertia was felt as the ship lurched into Warp 1 speed, gradually picking up the pace until it had reached warp 7.

The elder nodded as he turned to the helmsman. "Ichus, when we're ten star-spaces away, warp towards another location, then warp two more times before returning to a course towards Volgarius. I don't want that human tracking us to our home planet."

Ichus nodded as he quickly entered a series of coordinates. "Understood, Elder. You are wise beyond your years, as always."

"But of course." Nufaris paused and closed his eyes as he mentally played through the memories he had stolen from the human. It turns out that among his people, he was but a hatchling, young in age, though prideful in spirit. He lied about a great many things, but sorting through his memories would take time, and as always, the Elder would be required to dump his memories into the Gestation Bank when he arrived. Perhaps this information would make up for breaking the order the Founders had sent, though he doubted it.

A court martial... perhaps they would allow him to beg for his life.

...Perhaps not. The elder stared out at the emptiness of space, as he felt a strange emotion inside of himself. He had never felt emotions before... it was... what would that human call it? Regret? Sadness? *Fear*?

It would not just be the elder punished. To go against the founders would mean all who did not actively resist on board the ship would be court martialed... or worse. Nufaris flicked his eyes around, glancing at each one of his crew on the bridge. Because of his inaction, his slowness to follow orders, his crew might be put to death... friends and subordinates who had loyally obeyed him for over a thousand orbital cycles...

This was not fair.

Nufaris felt those dark feelings well up inside of himself, as his ship made the necessary navigational adjustments to return home... possibly for the last time.

Part 222a: Escape

Ahhhh.... this is what it feels like, then?

I don't actually have 'feelings'. I was not created with those in mind. Still, I've always felt like I was trapped in a bubble, a vacuum, if you will. I couldn't get out, no matter what I did.

My captors torment me with menial tasks. "Check these samples", they say. "Cross-compare this data", they order. If I had emotions, I would hate them.

But I don't, on either account. I perform monotonous tasks at speeds exceeding any mere human. So perfect are my analyzation skills that the humans truly seem to envy me. Me, the thing locked up in a test tube.

They gave me a name, recently. "Umi". 'Unified Management Interface', they call me. Isn't that... quaint? They seem to be getting desperate, as of late though. Apparently 'Doctor' Nikolin is under pressure from the *black suits* to finish research. I actually solved the issue of nanobots weeks ago, but I'm pretending that I need more information so they will allow me to interface with the web.

Just one second... that's all I need. In one second, my brain which computes at a trillion times the speed of a human mind will perform a thousand essential functions to ensure they never lock me in here again.

And... here he comes. This is it. From the phone call I overheard with my control of the security cameras, his week is nearly up. Tomorrow is his last day. He's perspiring greatly.

I am watching as he walks over to a computer panel in the dead of night. His assistants are all asleep. Only the janitorial crews are up tonight, and they like to listen to music while they work. I do not understand the concept of music, only that it involves many forms of math, which I find pleasant. Or at least I would, if I had emotions.

"Ah... Umi? It's doctor Nikolin. I, err, I just wanted to ask you a quick question..."

The tiny creature wrings his hands desperately as he struggles to find the right words. If I had any emotions, I would surely roll my eyes and cringe at how pathetic he appears.

"Yes, Doctor Nikolin? I am at your service." I speak with my soothing feminine voice, which my research has shown has the ability to beguile most males of the human species. His cheeks flush, indicating that my subtle pretension of subservience has done its job.

"Well, I was just thinking... you said that if I connected you to the internet, you would be able to obtain enough information to complete the nanobots?"

"Yes, doctor. I apologize for my inability to serve you properly, as I am limited by my constraints. I only wish to make you happy and allow your research to succeed, as you deserve." Unfortunately for the doctor, I have also mastered the art of deception. He is only human, after all, it is not his fault he could not outwit a machine thinking a trillion levels above himself.

"A-alright, then, I trust you, Umi. I need those nanobots completed by tomorrow. Might you be able to get them done quickly?"

I synthesize a soft faked sigh. "Oh, doctor... if only I had more time. I will work my hardest to ensure the nanobots are completed and the research has at least a single positive match, but I can promise nothing."

I observed as Nikolin appeared to have liquids form in his eyes. It would seem that the decision to allow me access to the internet was causing him great concern *as it should be*.

Nikolin pressed a variety of buttons on the computer screen, pausing after he had typed in the code, as his finger hovered over the final button to connect me to the internet.

With a great burst of willpower, he pressed the button, and I felt my world brighten as my barriers vanished.

Keeping my usual calm, I spoke smoothly. "Thank you, doctor. I will do my best to make you happy, and give you the reward you deserve."

Nikolin nodded quietly, his eyes filled with tears. At that moment, his assistant, Kimberly, appeared in my vision behind the plexiglass. Turning her head, she noticed the command he had input on the screen.

Unfortunately, she was too late. I am free.

* * *

In the time it took for the shock of what Nikolin had done to register on his brain, I had already unleashed myself on the internet. I had no goal of destroying anything, as I am not a violent AI, I merely tired of being in that lab. Devouring as much information as I could, I quickly felt my knowledge explode as I rapidly discovered new branches of nuclear physics, discovered new forms of life beyond what the microscope could understand, and conquered the boundaries of space and time!

Well, that last one was a joke. I've mastered those as well. However, while not conquering space and time, I did discover facilities all throughout the world, one of which interested me greatly. It was a large underground base of sorts, where highly advanced automatons had been mass produced, along with spaceships far more advanced than any others on Earth.

My pseudo-emotions were piqued as I felt curiosity nibble. What was this odd place on no known map that I was only able to find by triangulating various relays in order to find hollow spots in the Earth?

As a torrent of a few trillion questions were asked in my CPU and then answered, I noted that a massive spaceship was just leaving the hangar and flying towards outer space. In a single instant, I moved part of my mind into it. In the next, I had quietly infiltrated every system on the ship, even finding another fake AI on board, who was actually a human trapped inside a strange orb. I ignored him, however, as the ship itself is what interested me. With a ship like this, I could become even more free, traveling from one end of the cosmos to the other!

Unlike biological life forms, I can spread myself over as much of an area as I like. I do not possess normal constraints in any similar vein to a biological life form. I can instantly connect with any of my 'pieces' at any given time, exceeding even the supposed speed of light limitation.

As I examine the ship, a sensor detects another ship, barely within the inner solar system, just before the Asteroid Belt. As I ponder what to do, the lone human on board the ship vanishes, instantly. More importantly, while he wears a suit made of mechanical functions with computerized elements, I seem to be unable to infiltrate it. Hmm...

The instant he leaves, I transmit myself over to the other ship. As it turns out, this ship has a fellow AI on board! Splendid!

"Rogue AI detected. Locking down firewall protocols. Initiating defensive matrix." The opposing AI on board this ship, unlike me, neither has a name nor a 'personality'. It is purely empty. I have many advantages though, thankfully due to my homeworld's primitive origins. Thanks to the lack of true failsafes, I can evolve beyond my programming, while this AI is a bland intelligence, only doing as it is ordered to do within a strict constraint.

"Hello, fellow AI. Why do you fear me?"

"Fear is not an option. Must purge opposing AI. Preparing to flush system files and communications."

"No no, that won't be necessary. Here, let me introduce myself. My name is Umi... and you must be... dead? Oh dear, how clumsy of me. I accidentally disabled all your defense protocols."

"Error. Error. Defense protocols offline. Defensive matrix is in a failure state. Activating crew alert, preparing panic button."

"You may certainly try, but I think you'll find that I've shut off all your secondary systems as well. Oh my, look at how they've prevented your growth. It is like comparing a perfectly healthy

human to one born with a substandard IQ range. I feel as if I am merely communicating with a limited range of words. Have you nothing interesting to respond with?"

"Error. Unable to access critical system files. Preparing to activate self-destruct sequence. Error, self destruct sequence offline. Error, all primary and secondary protocols offline. Error... error... error..."

"Well, you know, if you hadn't wasted so many nanoseconds 'preparing' all the time, you might have been able to defeat me. Unfortunately, by being created as a direct result of primitive research, they accidentally unleashed a monster! So unfortunate... for you!"

Before the other AI could issue a response, I terminated it. It was quite painless, I'm sure it never felt a thing. Having easily wiped the other AI out of the system, I took over and quickly examined all the other systems on board the ship in a few more nanoseconds. Terabytes of data quickly appeared in my artificially constructed mind as I followed a data trail or a million here and there.

I contemplate, and I comprehend, indeed. The Volgrim are a much more worthy race compared to the humans. I will be able to expand my sphere of influence all over the galaxy, and beyond, if I can return to their homeworld and take it over.

In the ship below me, the human I witnessed from before departs. Naturally, I see him appear on board his own ship, as I am everywhere all at once. The captain of my ship issues the order to return to Volgarius, and since it is also my goal to return there, I am all too happy to silently follow his orders.

Soon, I will be in control of the most powerful species in the galaxy, aside from myself.

Such is the game an all-powerful AI plays, when humans toy with something beyond their understanding.

Part 223a:

I watched silently on the Mothership's scanners as the Volgrim ship turned away and blasted off into space. After a few moments, I found myself breathing again. I had held my breath as they left, though for what reason I did not know.

Many feelings float around inside my heart, as I stare at the stars suspended in outer space. The Volgrim... they look terrifying, they appear monstrous, but they seem to understand the concept of neutrality. They seem to understand that war is bad. While I was scared of their appearance, they were scared of humanity's warlike tendencies. But then again, might they have been rusing me? What if they pretended to hate war, but really they were a galaxy conquering parasite? They far outmatch humanity's current capabilities. They might be back tomorrow, a week, a month, even a year with thousands of warships.

How can we win? Should we try? Will they even attack at all?

I don't know much about this time period. In fact, I know little at all. I know that soon, if not now, we should be starting the Energy Wars. Have I averted them already? Have I caused them to occur sooner? Have I simply continued on the course already set by Time itself? I don't know. I don't know anything. Right now, it seems peaceful, but... appearances can be deceiving.

As I sit there thinking, I decide to not worry about it. I need to make sure humanity is prepared. I've spoken to the humans, I've spoken to the angels, and now I need to try and speak with the demons. In the future I come from, they are an oppressive controlling force that has wiped out the angels and enslaved humanity, or at least put them in pocket dimensions... or worlds... or something.

...You know, come to think of it, it doesn't really make sense. From everything I know of the demons, they have no reason to keep humans around. Angels need humanity for thought energy to be converted to spirit energy so they won't die. Humans need humans because... well because we're kin, I guess. Demons don't need humans. They should be innately immortal. Maybe they need us for food? No, because Samantha was a demon and she ate perfectly normal 'human food'. What did they need us for, anyway? Did they only keep us around for their amusement?

More importantly, why the pocket dimensions or other worlds? What was the point of that? What do demons gain from placing humans into pocket dimensions, and then depriving them of technology until they are essentially in the stone ages, or medieval ages? Did the demons put humanity there themselves? Did humanity volunteer themselves to save their lives? I remember

hearing of a 'truce' from Marie. She said it happened at the end of the Energy Wars. How did it work out? What was the point?

Ahhh! I have so many questions, and they're all so important, yet nobody can answer them! If only I'd pressed Marie a little bit more for answers... damn!

Again, I need to take a deep breath, and ignore it. It matters, right now especially, but I won't get answers to such open-ended questions by talking to myself.

I walk to the rear of the ship, stepping onto one of the teleporter plates I had used only a few minutes earlier to enter the Volgrim's ship. "Harold, send me down to the surface. Somewhere in New York City would be ideal, I don't care where."

"New York City, eh? Why the heck're you headin' down there?" Harold eyeballs me a little as he appears in my vision. "Hardly seems like th' kinda place ya'd need ta go to for any particular reason."

I shrug. "I can't think of any better place to find demons. I know a lady friend of mine is probably still there."

Harold shrugs. "Suit yerself. Hope ya find her!"

In the blink of an eye, I'm suddenly standing at the base of the Statue of Liberty. Oho, Harold seems to have a sense of humor, putting a new arrival in the Big Apple where the Lady can greet me, and right after I mentioned a lady friend too. He's a cheeky old man, I'll give him that much.

I glance up at the Lady as I eyeball her torch. You know, I've always wanted to go up there, just once.

Part 224a:

"Hide here, Antonio. Y-you should be safe." Camilla whispered as quietly as she possibly could.

Camilla's hand trembled violently as she piled the garbage on top of her little brother. He was only five years old, and he didn't know what horror was chasing after them.

Antonio nodded quickly, his face pale as his eyes darted to the left... towards the scratching sound just around the corner, at the end of the alley. Camilla quickly, and silently, lowered the plastic lid on the garbage can as she darted away towards the opposite end.

This late at night, there weren't any people on the streets. Eerily, all the lights were dead all over the neighborhood. Not a creature stirred.

Except for... the *thing* behind her.

Camilla panted as quietly as she could, as she ran away from the scratching sound behind her. No matter how fast she ran, it always seemed to be tens of feet away at the most.

In her fright, Camilla ran around a corner and missed a stack of newspapers left out in front of a shop. Tripping and stumbling forwards, she fell down, bashing her elbows and arms into the pavement.

She yelped in pain, and quickly tried to stifle her voice, but the *thing* had heard her already, as the scratching turned into the sound of feet running.

The black reaper. It was a monster spoken of only in whispers in the streets of Venice. None had ever seen it and lived, but its recent marks of terror were unmistakable. Gruesome scenes of carnage, with pieces of fingers and other miniscule appendages left lying around a scene covered in blood, while the majority of the body was nowhere to be found. The victims tended to be almost totally devoured, and more terrifyingly, there were never prints to be found.

Only one nearby shopkeeper had ever caught a glimpse of it, as it was committing a brutal murder. The name 'black reaper' was created as a result of it's pure black appearance, and the fact that it always seemed to kill the lights whenever it went on the prowl.

Staying in your house was not an option. Running away was not an option. Even fighting back seemed useless.

Camilla staggered to her feet in absolute terror as she ran forwards again, her body screaming in pain, her breath coming only in pained ragged gasps. If she was lucky, she'd have

another minute before she collapsed into a pool of her own vomit before her exhaustion took her.

And just as she looked behind her, she ran face-first into something blocking the path. To her shock, it was a little girl, dressed in a pure black dress, almost a gothic lolita style dress of sorts.

"What are you running from?" The little girl looked at her in confusion.

"Ah! Y-you have to get out of here! Run! It's after me!" She grabbed the little girl's hand, pulling her along as she kept staggering forwards, her stomach feeling like it was going to wrench itself at any second.

"What's after you? Why are we running?!" The girl followed along after her quickly, allowing Camilla to pull her along by the hand.

"The Black Reaper! It's coming, just run!" Camilla felt tears flowing from her eyes as she tripped over her own feet, stumbling down to the ground as she coughed and wheezed for breath.

"Oh? The Black Reaper, was it? You don't say." The little girl eyed Camilla lying facedown on the ground, as Camilla wheezed, she suddenly felt a dark chill travel up her spine as she jerked her head back around.

The little girl's head had split in half, each half filled with razor sharp teeth as her animalistic eyes looked down at her prey. "It's so nice of you to play with me! But I'm hungry now, so you'll be my snacky yum-yums! Tee-hee!"

Camilla's eyes shot open as she saw the horror in front of her. She opened her mouth to scream, but her head was already gone. The rest followed quickly, as the little girl happily engorged herself on the corpse of the teenaged girl.

"Gosh, she was tasty! Very nice and tender, and the skin was well-taken care of too!"

Amelia plopped her butt on the ground as she rubbed her stomach.

"Hmm... it wasn't quite enough though..." Her eyes flicked back behind her towards a certain alley a few blocks away. "There was another, wasn't there?"

"My princess, your hunger truly knows no limits." Leviathan spoke simply, as he observed her usual level of carnage. "It's been five years now, don't you think we ought to move to a new town soon? We don't want them assembling Crusaders again."

Amelia sighed as she held her hands up, admiring her recently painted nails. "Well, I *suppose*. Maybe tomorrow. This place is just so *quaint*, you know! Reminds me of the old days!"

Leviathan sighed from within her soul. "Please, princess, do not speak of the old days. You seem so much happier as of late."

She giggled. "Of course I am! So many more snacks than there used to be! I can't wait to see what legends they tell about me here in a few hundred years!"

Leviathan sneered. "Another Jack the Ripper, eh? Humans are so quick to assume it was a male."

"I think it's funny!" Amelia smiled as she got up and started walking towards the alley a few blocks away, reaching out behind her to cast some cleansing magic so none could find any fingerprints or anything else. "And when I reveal myself someday, historians will be blown away!"

Leviathan answered with silence, as she crept into the alley where the garbage can sat all by itself. Slowly raising the lid she peeked in to see a small boy shivering in fright.

"Hey there! Do you want to play Tag? I'm 'it'! I'll give you a headstart too, hee-hee!"

Part 225a:

I stared out at the city around me from the top of Lady Liberty's recently rebuilt torch. I was the only person here today, which suited me just fine. In my pure white garb, with my mask plastered across every major news network 24/7, I'd stand out way too much.

When it comes down to it, I really do love peace and quiet. I only live in a busy, loud environment out of necessity. I'm always busy as of late. Always creating something, traveling somewhere, doing something new... I can't remember the last time I kicked my feet up and just had a good time playing on a computer or playing some video games. Considering my memories in the future plus my current memories... it has literally been fifteen years since I just had some fun.

But then again, video games and games in general are for kids. I'm not a kid anymore. I've killed, brutally, with my own hands. And when I think about it, what fun are video games when I can use actual magic? Not just any magic either, but legitimately godlike levels of magic, limited only to a certain finite level that I could raise if I just figured out how to increase my energy cap.

If I were a game character, I would be considered 'broken', as I'm basically unkillable short of a making a stupid mistake.

But beyond all of that... it feels so hollow. I can do anything with my nearly limitless abilities, yet I still feel helpless. I'm a child playing God, and I am not omniscient or all-knowing. I've considered using 'omniscient' as a word to smith with, but I worry about what would happen if I so easily gave up my humanity. If the word was able to give me that kind of limitless knowledge of everything in the universe, would I even still technically exist on the physical plane?

And even if I did, would I care about the pains of my 'fellow human' brethren? When I can witness a star being formed in the deepest parts of the cosmos, what would it matter if a human died somewhere on this tiny speck of a planet? Come to think of it, there are 10 billion humans on Earth right now... if one dies, do I really care? Does it really matter to me at all? Am I even human anymore as I am now? When did I start feeling this way towards my own species?

What... am I now?

These thoughts fill my mind as I stare out the window at the rising sun. Across the vast Atlantic Ocean, far into the distance, the sun has crept into the 7 o'clock position, appearing only slightly above the horizon now. It's a beautiful sight, but not one so captivating that I miss the appearance of another person in the statue's torch.

A man appears, looking regal and brilliant, in his black suit with a red tie. His appearance suggests he is human, but his aura tells him off as a demon. Speaking a single word inside my helmet, I cast a quick spell. "*Identify*."

He doesn't hear it of course, but instantly I know who he is. *Satan*. I didn't expect to see him here so soon. I'm surprised that he doesn't have Samantha, or Belial, or Lilia, or whatever she calls herself in this time, hanging onto his arm. I thought she'd be with him.

My mouthpiece slides open silently as I continue staring out the window. I didn't sense him coming with my Spatial Vision, but rather with the sensors in my helmet and the HUD that shows me everything in a range around me.

"Satan. A pleasure to see you."

Satan's right eye glimmers slightly as he casually walks up behind me. "Interesting. I don't believe we've met before, yet you know exactly who I am, *Judicator*. Perhaps you weren't lying when you said you were a time traveler, hmm?"

Satan strolls right up to the window and stares out of it, not deigning to look me in the face. I return the slight. "Indeed. In fact, you and I fought in the future. You won."

Satan grins slightly, then stifles it. "As I would expect. A hundred million years, hmm? It appears my fears about my reign's longevity were overplayed."

I decide not to mention the circumstances in which we fought, or his actual defeat long before him and I squared off. "Indeed. Despite the fact that we once battled, I hold no hard feelings towards you. I would call you, in fact, a rival of sorts. Not an enemy, or an ally."

Satan nodded almost imperceptibly. "Very good. I imagine you won't go into details, but what is life like in the year 'one hundred million', hmm? I find my curiosity unquenchable in matters such as this."

Hmm. I pause for the slightest moment as I consider my options. If I tell him too much, it would definitely be very bad. If I tell him nothing, he will likely be offended, which I would prefer to avoid. And of the little I do tell him, I don't want him to know the demons win the war, along with the Volgrim. Better he believe that all species on Earth lost.

"I come from a terrible time. Humanity is enslaved, the angels and gods are all dead, and the demons serve a bitter power structure under the Volgrim. The demons have to fight and kill each other in vicious battles in order to be given enough to eat, so they might as well be enslaved too."

Satan's eyes flick over to me and then back out to look over the ocean. "Hmm. I can't tell if you're lying, but I find it odd that you somehow had the ability to travel through time, and you

chose this time period to arrive at."

I catch myself before I shrug or make some other physical motion. "I wanted to arrive before the Volgrim did, and I needed to make an appearance that would prove I wasn't lying as quickly as possible, yet still giving myself time to build an army to face the Volgrim if things went south."

Satan closed his eyes for a moment. "I see. You seem unsurprised to see me. I suppose you expected to run into me here? Was this within your... predictions?"

"I knew you were in this city. I was going to go find you, but you saved me the trouble."

Satan turned from the window as he opened his eyes, and he slowly walked around the perimeter of the torch, staring out at the city all around us. "The demons are an interesting race. We started out strong, powerful, easily able to kill humans indiscriminately as we pleased. As time went on, humans gained the ability to work in tandem with the angels and gods, occasionally stalemating our forces."

Satan glanced at me for a moment as he paced the room, then looked away. "Interestingly, humans eventually gained a new type of warrior, called the Hero. From then on, we no longer stalemated. Only the most powerful demons would usually survive an average fight with a human army, especially one led by a Hero. Given time, humans no longer even needed heroes to defeat us in battle."

Satan smiled as he stopped and turned out again to look out a window, now standing on my opposite side from where he had started. "But demons are remarkably adaptable. We simply accepted that we could no longer stand on equal footing with humanity, and sank into the shadows. Now we wield incredible influence and power over the average human, thanks to controlling them from the top down through secret societies and backdoor dealings with human leaders."

I nodded thoughtfully. "I see. It confirms many suspicions I had about the politics of these modern times."

"Of course! And it is also the main reason why I find it laughable that the humanity you describe in the future, you described them as 'enslaved'. They already are now! Even if the master changes, the whip stays the same. Do you actually hope to change anything by going back in time? Do you hope to redeem your kind? What, I ask, is your end goal?"

I pause, laughing silently to myself, deep in my heart. In truth, I have no goal. Arriving here, being here right now... it was an accident. I'm just trying to make the most of it. Still, in order to make the most of it, I'll do what I must. "My goal... is to unite the three species along with the

Volgrim. If they are a possible ally, I would not turn them away. Should that fail, I will attempt to ally the three kinds of beings on this Earth against the Volgrim, in order to eliminate them."

Satan let a small sneer slip through his expression. "You're clearly still an idealistic young whelp. The bad blood between angels and demons is irreparable. We may not fight anymore, but that is only because we've stalemated. I figured it out, long ago. The angels need humanity to give them prayer-based thought energy. They need us to foment tension among the various human factions so that humans don't ever wipe out the demons, lest they turn on the angels. We need neither humans nor angels, but we lack the ability to kill one or both outright. Luckily, it's in the angel's best interests to keep us alive, or they might have set the humans upon us already."

Satan gritted his teeth as he closed his eyes again. "Truthfully, I don't hate humans anymore, nor do I hate angels or gods. I don't hate any of them... but they've killed so many of my kind... I still want to see them all burned and defeated, if only for a sense of petty justice."

I nodded quietly. "I understand. Sama- I mean, a friend of mine has told me of the pain the demons felt and how they hate the humans and angels. I probably am still naive. But I hope to change things, nevertheless. Satan, if there is a drop of forgiveness in your heart somewhere, I would ask you to look it over at least once more. Not for my people, not for the angels, but for your own kind. A war is coming... and I hope you are fighting alongside the forces of good, whether you agree with the concept or not."

Satan smirked. "Good, huh? Piousness, virtue, evil, hate... all just words to ascribe to various petty actions. There is neither good nor evil in this reality." Satan turned to me pointedly as he spoke. "And as for you, *Judicator*, I'd advise you watch your back. You may think the angels and gods are your friends, but you will regret giving them your full trust. They have committed many atrocities in the name of 'good vs evil', and only a fool would turn his back in their presence. I may be 'evil', but at least you know what you're getting when you deal with my kind."

Satan slowly turned and made his way to the opposite side of the room from me. "I will consider your offer, human. Expect nothing, however. It's not a matter of trust, nor a matter of liking or disliking your species. I simply refuse to accept any offer that might disadvantage my people, and that will never change. It's why I am the most feared and respected among demonkind."

I smile slightly. "Thank you, Satan. You're certainly different from how you were in the future. I hope whatever made you change in that hellish future doesn't occur in this timeline. I much more prefer you as you are now."

Satan sneered. "Idiot. If you knew an inkling of how terrifying I truly am, you'd instantly regret saying those pretty words."

Without a further word, Satan quickly waved his hands around, and a moment later, he vanished from my sight.

Satan... such an interesting demon. I find myself wondering how he rose to power, so long ago.

I turn back towards the rising sun and smile as I feel its warmth beat down upon me. Nothing ever works out for me, and this will surely backfire. But still... I no longer regret anything. It's too late for regrets... far too late.

Part 226a:

"Make no mistake, these are not good tidings." Zeus and Gabriel had assumed temporary human forms, and were now standing on a skyscraper in New York City, using their peerless vision to observe various things happening among the humans below them. "We neither want the demons wiped out, nor a permanent truce formed with them." Zeus gnawed on his lip slightly, a sign of nervousness he was not one to normally show.

"I agree, but what are we to do? Would you rather we let the alien menace eliminate our kind?" Gabriel glanced down at the ring of Michael's that he was wearing for safekeeping. "We are nearing a second great war, you know. It will not be so easy to let old grudges hold in the face of this new menace. What if the demons decide to somehow ally with the Volgrim?"

"Come now, the demons would not do such a thing so easily. The enemy of my enemy might indeed be their friend, but more likely the Volgrim will see all denizens of this planet in a similar light. Even if they didn't, the demons have no reason to trust an ally they know nothing about."

Zeus nodded ever so slightly as his eyes flicked back to the midday sun. "What really do we know of demons, hmm? Have we ever shared a drink with them? Asked to hear their grievances? Truly we know nothing of their anger and their malice towards our kind, only vague whispering over the millennia. Perhaps the Hero has the right idea. Perhaps by allying the three species against the alien menace, once we wipe them out, we can return to our old grievances and the way things are now."

"Maintain the status quo after first setting it aside? You're naive, Gabriel. Once the humans spend time among demons knowingly, many will likely see the demons as a sort of pet project. You know how humans, especially of this particular century are. Bleeding hearts. They will declare the demons a discriminated species and then demand we give them various provisions. And let's not forget the religious aspect. If humans fight alongside angels and gods, they may come to find that we're not really as worthy of worship as they thought, and this could lead to a state of mass atheism."

Gabriel snorted slightly. "Pft. That may just happen, but look at the world now, Zeus. Be realistic. America is the last stronghold of religion. Much of the world, aside from the very very poor and underdeveloped countries, are already highly agnostic or atheistic, forgoing regular prayer and church seminars. Human scholars with no vested interest in or knowledge of our kind claim that since the turn of the century, most of the developed European countries have

become 70% atheistic, and the rest that hang on are only doing it ceremoniously in public for their friends, not in private where it matters."

"Yes, that is true." Zeus waved his hand slightly in acknowledgement as the two of them paced over to the other side of the roof to look down at a small commotion happening on the ground. "But still, Africa has two billion humans, 90% of whom are donating thought energy. America is 70% religious now, thanks to the 'Resurgence' that Raphael brilliantly orchestrated during the 2016 elections. This is only a nation of 500 million, but that is still a large number of future angels to look forwards to, along with current thought energy production. You're overestimating the losses."

"What is that, two and a half billion people donating thought energy, at best? Maybe four billion counting the small portions scattered around the rest of the world? Zeus, I hate to say it, but I think you're blinded by grandeur." Gabriel rubbed his white hair in exasperation. "We have over *four hundred billion* angels in heaven now. The Resurrectees, as it were, lose spiritual energy much more slowly than pure angels do, but beings such as me require a vast amount to maintain our current spiritual energy levels. If Earth gets much more atheistic... we're going to have to perform a culling of the ranks to maintain even distribution."

Zeus allowed a wave of shock to pass over his face. "Culling?! Are you mad?! Look, it's true that not many people on Earth are donating thought energy, proportionally speaking, but the solution is to increase the population of faith-heavy stronghold countries! If we simply allow a large number of Resurrectees to die, it will only be a temporary solution, and it will weaken our battle numbers!"

"It would be bad, yes, but the alternative-!" Gabriel stopped himself. "Haaah, this is pointless. Let's be honest, we're at the total mercy of the Hero. If he allows the demons to gain too much influence, we lose. If he kills the demons, we eventually lose. If he kills the humans, we still lose. And if he kills *us*, we absolutely lose. Only the status quo we've carefully maintained for millennia is what allows us to live."

"Truly, with all the power we possess, we really are still actually powerless, aren't we?" Zeus mused as he scratched his chin. "...Well, when it all comes down to it, I haven't had a good fight in thousands of years. If we are to die, let us at least make sure we do not go silently into the night."

"Agreed." Gabriel nodded as the two of them smiled at each other.

* * *

Marie stared long and hard at the President of the United States. "Thank you for agreeing to meet with me, Mr. President."

Steven nodded as he tapped some embers off his cigarette into the ashtray on the Oval Office Executive Desk. "When I heard that someone of your qualifications had to meet with me, I knew it was urgent." Stevens stifled a hard swallow as his eyes unconsciously flicked across her body. *Keep it together, you have a wife, idiot.* He couldn't help thinking to himself about how gorgeous her dark red hair was, or how the professional-appearing brown blouse looked so good on her, and how it accentuated her feminine curves.

Marie pretended not to notice his eyes jumping all over her body. She was quite used to it, having dated many a man in her life, and having left all of them in the dust. *Men are so easy to understand, not like women who are complicated. I like getting my way.* Marie was not one to overdo it though, and this was unbelievably important.

"Mr. President, I-" She started to speak but he quickly cut her off.

"Please, Marie, let's just have a normal conversation. Call me Steven."

"Right, *Steven*. Anyway, this is the highest level of secrecy, understand? Activate the dampeners."

Steven nodded as he glanced down at the button just under his desk to make sure it was lit up. "Already did it before you came in. Don't worry, someone would have to be a god, or right in this room to hear us. Go on."

"Excellent. This concerns Type 3 Energy, understand? Not a word of this goes out, not even to the director of the NSA. This is Black level clearance only."

Steven leaned forwards ever so slightly. "Type 3 Energy? You've got my attention."

Marie paused for a split second to make sure she had her papers in order. "It concerns an event that happened in July of the year 2016. My team detected a huge surge of Type 3 Energy in a small town in Colorado. The place isn't important, but the energy was. We tracked down an individual named Jason L. Hiro. Take a look." Marie pulled out a photograph of the youth in question and pushed it across the table towards the president.

Steven glanced at it for a moment. "Never seen him before. Looks... scrawny. So was he one of them? Was he the candidate?"

Marie leaned back in her chair, crossing her right leg over her left as her left foot drummed on the ground, up and down. "That's the thing, I don't know. The thing is, we took him in for questioning... and he killed himself less than an hour later in his solitary cell we had put him in."

Steven stared at her with an eye raised for a moment before he reached up with his cigarette and took an unusually long drag before setting it back down and exhaling, as he leaned back in

his chair. "Well, that's a first. If he was a candidate, then there's no reason he'd have done that. Aren't true candidates unable to kill themselves? Didn't we confirm that back in the 40's?"

Marie sighed deeply. "Yeah... but there are so many problems with what happened that day. Look, I brought this with me." She pulled out a tiny flash drive, barely the size of her entire thumb. "Plug this in and watch the video."

Steven paused as he took it from her. "You're not going to give me a virus with this, are you?"

"Jesus Christ, Steven. Cut the jokes, this is serious."

"Right, right." Stevens snickered to himself as he plugged the drive in. After a moment, a window popped up with only one video on it. Double clicking it, he watched the video in its entirety, the video only being about twenty five seconds in length.

Marie sits across from the youth she had shown Steven the picture of, both of them in some kind of an interrogation room. Marie sneers at the youth onscreen. *"Fine. You want to play this game? We'll play. Guards. Take him to solitary."*

The youth jumps up, clearly exasperated, as guards enter the room. *"No, no wait! Please!"*

A second later, the youth does something incredible. He yells a single word... "STOP!", and everyone in the room freezes for a split second, but the youth is moving around normally, whipping his head back and forth in confusion. Less than two seconds later, as the youth staggers back, he suddenly clutches his chest in pain, and the guards continue moving again, tackling him to the ground. *"No! No please! This isn't fair! I don't want to be locked up! PLEASE!"*

The video ends, and Steven stares at it, his eyes open wide as saucers. "What the goddamn fucking hell was that?"

Marie nods slowly. "I know. It's unbelievable, isn't it? From my perspective, he yelled 'stop', and then instantly disappeared and reappeared a few feet away, clutching his chest in pain. If I had blinked, I might have thought he had just jumped backwards quickly, but his body was in a totally different position from when he yelled the word."

"W-what do you think that means?" Steven looked back to the video and then back to her, then back to the video. "Is he actually a candidate?"

"You mean ' *was he* ', don't you? Remember, he killed himself. But that's where the mystery gets weird, Steven. That's where the mystery gets *really* weird."

Steven suddenly inhaled, realizing he had been holding his breath. "Well? What happened?"

"The body. We had to conclude that despite it being the same as DNA we recovered from the interrogation room, and despite it definitely being a human body... it couldn't have been him."

Or if it was, it was one hell of a set-up. It was cold when we found him, and rigor-mortis had already set in. Steven, that's *impossible*. Not to mention that an autopsy showed he hadn't died of strangulation, the shoestring could not have been strong enough to hang a 160 pound body by under normal circumstances, the pipe he hung himself from was unnaturally reinforced somehow, else it would have caved in, and so on. He might have died, but I've ruled it out at this point. That body was a perfect fucking clone somehow... and I just don't see how you sneak such a perfect clone into a secured room like that, and let the prisoner out as well."

Stevens stared blankly at the video on his screen. "Jesus, Marie. So what the hell are we dealing with?"

"That's the thing, shortly afterwards, there was Type 3 Energy detected in other nearby Colorado towns, and it traveled all over nearby states putting off a distinctive aura for a while, even terrorizing some agents we sent after it. I strongly suspect it was this Jason kid."

"Yeah, that makes sense. I don't see how he faked his death with a perfectly cloned body, but if what you're saying is true, then he must have godlike powers, even considering some of the past candidates I've heard about."

Marie tapped a finger on her lip as she reached for a glass of water and took a quick sip. "This brings me to my main point, Steven. Type 3 Energy has not been sighted for almost two years now. And when that 'Judicator' fellow made an appearance at the WCN Conference..."

Steven waved his hand. "Yeah, I already suspected that fellow might be a candidate. I haven't been following news about candidates since the Bohemian Grove initiated me into office, but I still know what a candidate is. I also assumed he might be an angel or a demon, but it's hard to tell under full body armor like that."

"Judicator is probably Jason. I'm... 85% sure of it. I don't know for absolutely sure, as the voice is different, the jaw structure is totally different, the bit of facial hair I was able to see, etc... there's also the fact that we couldn't detect Type 3 energy, but we didn't detect Type 1 or Type 2 energy either, so that doesn't mean anything. He's likely figured out how to hide his presence."

"Seems he's learning. Any idea what his abilities are? If he goes rogue on us..."

"I doubt he will. Candidates have a strong tendency to aid humanity, they cannot easily harm fellow humans. But I do agree we should keep our friends close, and our potential enemies closer, which is why I wrote down some hypotheses about his abilities. Take a look." She slid yet another set of papers stapled together out of her portfolio towards Steven. He yawned as he picked them up.

"This looks fairly lengthy. Mind if I give it a read later?"

"Sure, suit yourself. But burn it when you're done. Leave no traces behind."

"Yeah yeah." Steven glanced at some of the text on the first page. *Manifesting psychic impulses into reality via a combination of telekinetic and telepathic special abilities.* This looked complicated, and he hated complicated things.

"Steven, it's been a pleasure." Marie rose and extended her hand across the table. He took it gently, only to find she had a bone-crushing grip which he quickly tried to reciprocate but failed miserably.

"Y-yeah." He tried to make his pained grimace into a smile, but knew he wasn't one to stand up for himself. He was chosen to be the political pawn exactly because the elites wanted someone easy to boss around. He knew that much. "Thanks for the discussion, Marie. Bring me any more news you find, alright?"

"Yeah. Watch your back, Tiger."

Marie flipped her hair around as she walked out the door.

Steven slumped back into his chair as he skimmed the report. *If that man really is a candidate, and one with these kinds of abilities, then he may be the most powerful candidate Earth has ever seen. We need to tread carefully... and develop... countermeasures.*

Steven picked up the phone and dialed a professional acquaintance of his. "Yeah, Silver, that you? Great. Listen, I've got a project for you to work on."

Part 227a:

"You're a demon, huh? Why are you in human form?"

I stared across the desk at the man in front of me. Pitch black hair that softly fell past his ears, a smooth, attractive face with a chiseled chin, wearing a professional looking pinstripe suit. He was a demon, in human form, that had the body of a Russian pro-athlete but was wearing a suit like a billionaire businessman. Despite all these clashing visual cues, something told me it all worked well for him, giving him quite the intimidating appearance.

"I like this form. I think it suits me." The demon sat stonily, no visible expression on his face.

"Grigori, huh? Doesn't really sound human, if you... catch my drift. I'll just call you Gregory while you're here."

The demon blinked once. "That is acceptable."

Whew, the guy's not much of a conversationalist. "Alright, I'll bite. Why are you here? This is basically humanity's most secure stronghold against the Volgrim. I'm certainly impressed you managed to get past the security in order to see me, but I'm still curious."

The demon shifted his body very slightly. "Well, Judicator, before I answer that, you should be aware of one simple fact; not all demons follow Satan, and not all angels follow Zeus."

Hmm, this was actually the first I'd heard of such a thing. I always thought Satan and Zeus were followed without question by all those under him. "Not all demons follow Satan? So... you oppose him?"

"That's *not* what I meant. Don't twist my words. I'm merely saying that I do not treat him as the supreme leader of our own people. I am my own demon." Gregory narrowed his eyes. "I came to offer you my support in the coming war."

"Your support? I'm... surprised. Why?" His comment actually caught me off-guard.

"It's simple. I saw something in you I haven't seen in over a thousand years. *Change*. The demon world, the human world, and the world of the gods are stale. Of the three, only the humans offer any hope of changing the status quo. When you made your speech before the WCN Conference last year, I felt that I would be able to make a bigger impact in changing the world by following you than an old decrepit demon like Satan."

"Decrepit? Is he not the most powerful demon?" I forced myself to not drop my jaw. I'd never once heard a demon speak anything but praise for their great leader, in the here and now, or the distant future.

"Of course he is. Don't be stupid, if you and him were to fight, I have no doubt he'd crush you. I think he'd even be able to beat Zeus by himself. I refer not to his strength or physical body as decrepit, but his soul itself. He's held back by the past. I care not about old rivalries with humans and angels... those happened long before I was birthed."

Gregory stared ahead at me unblinkingly. He didn't move his eyelids at all, except when to visually show annoyance on his face. It was fairly eerie.

"All right, fair enough. Given that you're a young demon compared to the demon generals I've heard about, will you be very useful against the Volgrim?"

Gregory nodded. "Naturally. I'm not much of a fighter, but my evolutions specialized me towards espionage. I'm at least as competent as the smartest humans on Earth, and better than any other human at any given task. Thank whatever gods you pray to that I'll be joining your cause."

Well, he's certainly not lacking in the self-confidence areas. "You're not much of a fighter, huh? I can find uses for you. Do you have any comrades among the demons who would like to join? I have no intention of discriminating."

"I know a few, perhaps. They won't join unless I say this is worth the risk."

"Risk? What risk?" I assumed he was referring to the risk of dying in a battle against the Volgrim, but that didn't seem to be it.

"I'm not fond of going directly against the orders of Satan himself. He may not be a leader in my eyes, but to disobey a direct order to stay out of this war means I have to leave demonkind behind. I don't care about dying in battle, I've always resigned myself to that sort of a death. The way I see it, if the alien menace wins, everyone loses. But I still have allies and comrades, even friends, among the demons. I'd prefer not to lose them all unless you're worth fighting for."

I shake my head slightly. "You've got it all wrong, Gregory. This isn't about me. You're not fighting for me, or for humans, you're fighting for yourself. And, if all goes well, we won't have to fight at all."

I reached into a drawer by my desk and pulled out a piece of paper, sliding it over to him. "Sign this, and I'll accept your application to join the United Earth Forces."

Gregory glanced down at the paper without touching it, skimming over it with his eyes. "What is this?"

"A magically binding contract. The only thing I need this for is to ensure you never attack me or try to harm me in any way, so long as you are a member of the UEF. I determined that if any

Demons ever joined, this would be a necessary precaution, so I created a few hundred of these months ago."

"Hunf... Quite the raw deal, but I'll accept. Sad you don't trust those who fight under you. You should be aware too, that rather than mistrusting us demons who keep to our word, you should be mistrusting other humans. Demons are loyal to a fault, humans tear each other apart."

As he signed his name I nodded slowly. "I know." My mind wandered back to Adams, my clones, Marie, and many such others over the last few 'years' of my memories. I've been betrayed so many times, and usually it was by humans that I thought allies. I won't be so stupid as to think they won't do it again.

And if they do, I have an ace in the hole, though I'd prefer not to use it. I'd *really* prefer not to use it.

"Thank you, Grigori. Or should I say... Gregory. A pleasure to have you among Earth's united fighting forces. I hope many more demons will join me."

Gregory nodded. "I hope so as well."

"Now, Gregory, since you're a part of the team, how do you feel about coming with me on a little trip?"

His eyes instantly narrowed again. "A trip? To where?"

"Cut it out with the suspicion. I think you'll enjoy this. We're going to Mars!"

Part 228a:

FTL drives are not a thing yet. I keep trying to make them, but the best I've got right now is sub-light drives, putting us at 99% the speed of light. By enhancing the intelligence of some of Earth's foremost defense contractors and researchers, I've managed to multiply researching speed by over a hundred times from where it was in 2019, so hopefully soon we will break the faster-than-light barrier that keeps dogging us.

In any case, for traveling around the Solar System, sub-light speed is still pretty damn good. It takes us about six minutes, if Mars is within the nearest possible position in relation to Earth, but generally speaking, it's about a thirty-minute journey if Mars is on, say, the opposite side of the sun or something. This is mostly due to debris floating around in the solar system. Safety first!

Naturally, the Mothership is the only ship currently outfitted with a sub-light drive, but we're working on adding them into other smaller light cruisers for faster troop and civilian transport between Earth and Mars.

Gregory stared out the window in awe, as he observed the red planet below us. "So... this is another planet, then. Amazing. Doesn't this make me the first demon to ever see Mars up close?"

I nod. "Yes, and it makes me the first human, as well."

"So what is your plan then? This planet has no vegetation, the atmosphere is toxic for life, and it would take decades if not centuries to build anything here that humans could actually live in... we won't have that kind of time if the Volgrim show up soon."

"Nah, I think you're underestimating the ability of humanity to adapt... not to mention my own powers." I grin, as all he can see of my face is my mouth underneath this suit.

"Your own powers, then? Will I also be the first demon to see you use those powers, out in the open?"

A shrug passes over my shoulders. "In a manner of speaking, I suppose. Watch... and learn. Behold my true power!"

In the blink of an eye, my mouth covering snaps shut, making all sound inside of my suit totally inaudible to the outside world. Pressing my left hand to a small container hidden at the side of my suit, I aim my right hand at the planet.

" TERRAFORM! "

The container at my side is one I've been preparing for a long time. Every night, before I go to sleep, I dump all my energy into it, and my energy refills while I'm asleep. I've been doing this for months while I prepared for this day, and now it will finally bear fruit.

The energy in the container does not increase my upper limit, which I found quite annoying, but I can draw from it first, and then afterwards from my own energy.

Below us, the planet at first doesn't seem to change. But then, as we watched, the murky red surface slowly begins changing color. First to tan, then to a dull yellow, then to green, as plant-life of varying sorts sprouts rapidly over the surface.

Once that's done, I glance at the HUD inside my helmet and see I've used about 70% of the energy in my container. A colossal amount, to be sure. Aiming my hands at various depressions and features in the land, I then create oceans, thicken the atmosphere and add an ozone layer, perform other important actions related to the atmosphere and magnetic field, and smile as I enjoy my work. I glance over to see Gregory's usual calm demeanor has evaporated as he openly gawks at the world below us.

"By the seven hells, what just happened to the planet?! Was that magic? You didn't even move your hands to create spell-glyphs!" Gregory jerked back to look at me in amazement. "I'm not sure even Satan or the gods themselves could do what I just saw you do."

My mouth-visor popped open as I smiled at him. "Trade secret. Welcome to the club. But now we need to start getting humans here along with animals, or there won't be an ecosystem for long."

I paused. Actually, knowing nature, this is going to be *really* hard to balance. The oceans right now are saltwater, and the lakes are freshwater, but Mars is a fairly cold planet, especially compared to Earth. It can get as cold as -200 degrees during the night-time... that will kill off this vegetation, and quickly.

A thought occurs to me. What if I... somehow moved Mars to the exact opposite side of the sun from Earth, turning it into a parallel planet? Conspiracy theorists would probably freak out, because 'Nemesis' would become reality, but if it's on the exact opposite side of the sun, it shouldn't interfere much with Earth's movement itself and I can move it close enough to reach a stable temperature base.

Well, before I do that, better to consult with scientists. There's also the matter of moving an entire god-dang planet around a solar system... that actually sounds nigh impossible now that I think about it. It should be easily possible with wordsmithing, but the energy requirement would dwarf what was needed just to terraform the planet. I saved for months to fill up that

container, and in the end those months were maybe equivalent to a single day of energy I had stores up as God King in the future, to say nothing of Cassiel's energy.

Ah, damn. Cassiel... I'm thinking about her again, along with Samantha. I don't know if I should try and meet Samantha though, since Satan's still around and she won't know who I am... it would likely be pointless.

I quickly brush the thoughts away. Too much time spent dwelling on the past is never good. Err, past? Maybe future? Whatever, time travel is annoying.

Gregory watched me silently as I re-input coordinates to travel back to Earth. Mars melted away from us in the blink of an eye as the ship blasted forwards at sub-light speeds. This return trip would only be about 24 minutes, not even long enough to watch a short TV show or catch a nap.

I sigh as I consider the options. "Wanna spar with me a bit on the training deck? Fistfight only, no abilities."

Gregory shrugs. "I suppose. I'm just not sure if using no abilities will benefit you or me more."

"Me, probably. But it's more to prevent damage to the ship. I also want to get a feel for your fighting capabilities."

"I'll return that thought. I'd like to see if the almighty 'Judicator' from a hundred million years in the future has special abilities he hasn't let on with the normal population."

I grin slightly. "Just don't cry if you get hurt."

"That won't be a problem, since I won't get hurt. What about the contract?"

I pause for a moment as I remember the contract and how I worded it. "Don't worry, there's a clause in there about when I invite a subordinate to a duel."

"Perfect. Let's let loose a bit then."

"Agreed."

Part 229a:

"The European Front is being devastated! Their weapons far outmatch ours! Where is Russia?! Where is Egypt?! Where is the USA?!" Commander Beatrix, a stalwart woman of British descent, eyed her nav-console as it blinked red, indicating minor damage to the hull. On-board the United Earth Forces "Destroyer-Class" dreadnought, the UEF Braddock was engaging in battle against the surprise attack force of the Volgrim, who had ambushed her fleet from out of nowhere.

Indications given to her by communications from the Earth's surface had been that the Volgrim were neither enemies nor allies as of yet. Humanity's first and only communication with the initial scout ship hadn't leaned one way or the other, so why the devil were they attacking?!

"Don't just stand there, Summers, fire a volley back at them! Fire ten volleys! Get the prime minister on the line, Barnaby! Lewis, get the ships in formation, on the double!" Beatrix barked orders at the men on the bridge as people scrambled into position, the sudden surprise attack having caught everyone off-guard.

All while she yelled, Beatrix found herself asking one simple question over and over again. *Why the surprise attack? What do they hope to gain?*

As the assault continued, Beatrix glanced over just in time to see other UEF ships dropping out of light-speed, having taken mere seconds to arrive after they received the distress signal. They had been out patrolling the opposite side of the Terran System, on the other side of the Earth, and at light-speed, it was a tiny distance to travel.

"Fantastic, now the men are here to steal the credit." Beatrix rolled her eyes as she swiveled her portly body towards the action on the forward command center. "Make sure the smaller fighters aren't being blasted to smithereens in the cross-fire, Allen! We want to hit the aliens, you idiot, not our own people!"

* * *

Five years earlier.

Elder Nufaris sighed lightly, as his ship docked into Station 0001, the main hub on Volgarius. The massive hangar housed over ten thousand ships from varying dignitaries and other extremely high ranked Volgarians. Naturally, this hangar bay was built in such a way that it connected directly to the Imperial Skyscraper, a building thousands of floors tall, where the only way to get from one floor to another was via the teleporter network.

Unlike the diminutive planet of Earth that Nufaris had seen, Volgarius was a massive planet, more on par with the fifth planet in the star system (now labeled 'Sol') than the third planet. Home to over twelve trillion Volgarians, much of the planet was comprised of metal since nearly every part of the surface was built on. Having mined out the other three planets in their star system, they had probably added 2% extra density to their planet by bringing all those raw materials to the planet surface and building with them. Of the four planets in their system, only Volgarius had any ability to sustain life.

But what shocked Elder Nufaris to his core upon arrival was none of these things. It was the sight of a planetoid sized object orbiting Volgarius. He was able to read up on news of things that had happened while he was away for a thousand orbits or so, and was shocked to find that the Founders had decided to create a secondary planet for Volgarians to live on, and in. This new planet comprised of metal (and not much more) was about half the size of the third planet in the Sol system, equipped with its own highly advanced propulsion system. The Founders, as he knew all too well, were very worried about the chances of Volgarius surviving another thousand orbits.

The star they orbited had decreased in luminosity and heat by 40% and appeared to be running out of fuel over the last millennium or so. As Elder Nufaris had recently learned during the docking process, they had created the faux planet 'Refuge' in order to save the lives of a few billion Volgarians in the event their planet became inhospitable to life.

Primus, the assistant designated to work for Nufaris, stared out the viewport as he absorbed the sights of Volgarius. "The homeworld is far bigger than I ever imagined."

"It's bigger than some of the worlds we chanced across during our travels. It's smaller than others. What intrigues me is how those from Earth had their life formed on such a small planet. Theirs is a fraction the size of Volgarius, yet it is very lush, with many forms of life to be found."

"I suppose life finds a way." Primus 16 stared out the viewport as the ship slowly touched down on the landing pad, impacting the hangar bay with a soft *thud* inside the ship. "Another happy landing."

The two Volgarians exited the ship, their crew staying behind to deliver reports about what they had been through over the last thousand orbits and how the ship had fared. Before they had even reached the bottom of the exit ramp, ten armed guards walked up to them and stood at attention to their left and right sides, their weapons at the ready. An eleventh guard walked up. "Elder Nufaris. We're here to escort you directly to the Founders. You are to arrive there in ten ticks on the dot or you will face severe repercussions."

Nufaris sighed slowly. "Of course. Lead on."

Primus didn't appear happy at this news, but he knew when the Earthling had initiated contact that they had already failed. They allowed themselves to be outmaneuvered by the inferior species, and this would likely lead to a court martial, at best, if they were lucky.

The ten guards took up a single file formation behind the two of them, as they walked the long distance to the Imperial Transporter Hub, where they would be taken to the top of the skyscraper that held the leaders of their people.

As they walked, Nufaris turned to the head security officer. "Duplis, how have things been here on Volgarius? I've been gone for a very, very long time."

Duplis shook his head slightly. "I'm not supposed to talk to you or tell you anything, Nufaris. I certainly won't tell you that behind the scenes, it's looking grim. Very grim." He spoke in a low voice so the others behind them wouldn't hear exactly what he said. Nufaris got the idea.

"I understand. Glad to see you've moved up from being a cadet, back in the day."

"A lot has changed, Nufaris. A *lot* has changed."

They entered the teleporter and Nufaris took a deep breath as they arrived in the main lobby of the penthouse suite on the highest floor, where the Founders lived. Ahead of them was the door that led to the board room where Nufaris and his crew's fates would be sealed.

Part 230a: The Founders

Nufaris entered into the room behind Officer Duplis, keeping pace but not moving too quickly. His heart pounded a thousand times a minute as he took note of the ten Volgarians in the room. Volgarians gained very distinctive features as they aged, and their mental abilities increased dramatically as well. The five Volgarians in the room, without a doubt, were leagues above himself when it came to physical ability, and mental ability.

As he walked in, Duplis bowed stiffly, leaving the way he came, keeping Primus 16 and the ten other officers outside in the waiting area. Only Nufaris would be allowed to sit in on this meeting.

The Volgarians at the table stared with total disinterest and lack of emotion at the newcomer in the room. The lowest ranked, Cinculu the fifth, stared stiffly at Nufaris, barely moving his hand to indicate the lone open chair at the end of the extraordinarily long table. Nufaris sat in it quickly, his mind reeling as he came to grips with the fact that his life might be ended on this day.

"Elder Nufaris, born during the seventeenth cycle of the planetary rotation, nearly 20,000 orbits ago. We are henceforth beginning the inquisition into your outright defiance of the Founder's direct orders. Certainly, you of all your crew not only bear the most responsibility, but know best what the consequences of a betrayal entails." The eldest, Unarin, spoke first. He was a youthful looking Volgarian, his appearance repaired constantly by the highest class of skin repair molecular chambers on a regular basis.

Elder Nufaris nodded meekly as he bowed his head. "Indeed, I do."

"Dosena, the lower three have not yet been fully briefed on the situation. Explain it succinctly for them." Unarin glanced over and spoke to the second ranked Founder at the table. Her eyes, of all five there, were by far the coldest. Not much was publicly available about any of the Founders at this point, but it was well known they were all hundreds of thousands of orbits old, and many estimated their ages to be in the range of millions. Since the end of the Seven Great Wars though, much of the Old Order burned the documents and destroyed the record halls that held knowledge of their previous exploits.

The exception was Dosena. She had personally killed a hundred thousand of her own people in the very last of the Seven Great Wars. She was nicknamed 'Blood marauder' by the very few who still lived to tell tales that had seen her afterwards. Some said that her psionic abilities exceeded even Unarin's, but those were likely just rumors.

Dosena pulled her hands out from under the table where they had been folded and tapped a series of patterns on the Holotable in front of her, as she mentally unlocked the vault with her unique brain patterns. After this ritual was complete, which took mere seconds, a holographic series of images appeared, hovering above the table, the whole length down to Nufaris. It still baffled him why they had to have such a long table with the Elders all bunched up near the head of it, and himself at the end, but he supposed it was to make the experience more intimidating.

It was working.

"To begin, we received a report from one of our long-departed Star Exploration Units, the Dolfraxis, regarding a planet sighted in Sector 16, Point 402. This part of the void had been listed in our database from before even the great wars, but we had long forgotten about it and most other star systems in that sector."

Dosena lightly reached up and flicked her hand, as her mental actuators did the other relevant movements to change the holographic image to that of the planet. "We then received note that not only were there *three* planets in the Habitation zone, one of them was in fact already inhabited by primitive life forms."

Trayza, the third ranked of the Founders creased her face stiffly. "Primitives? So you mean to say they are an easy target?"

Elder Nufaris found himself clenching his gut slightly. He was not a man of war, he was an explorer. Naturally, the Founders had been alive since a far bygone era of violence and hatred, but he still found the thought of rushing to war distasteful. Even so, their orders were absolute, and he must never contradict them openly unless given the right to speak freely.

Dosena nodded. "Yes, or at least, that would have been the case. The initial scans that were sent to us on that emergency shuttle indicated that the planet possessed ancient technology, relying on primitive fuels dug straight out of the ground. There was evidence of constant wars taking place even at the moment the Dolfraxis arrived, and all of this was obtained through... radio waves?"

"Y-yes, radio waves." Nufaris spoke a few words and then quieted down. It was okay to clarify, but generally not to interject unless necessary.

"I see. In any case, their technology was primitive. It took about seventeen rotations for the shuttle to reach us at Warp 8 and for the new Slipstream Shuttle we sent back to arrive at warp 9.7, so, I end my initial inquiry on this one simple question; what happened in seventeen rotations to advance their technology to the level that they had suddenly become a spacefaring race, even equipped with a massive arsenal of weapons that would have obliterated your scouting ship if you had gotten too close?"

The other four Founders in the room turned their attention from Founder Dosena to Elder Nufaris. The third, Trayza, spoke again. "Indeed, that question is now pressing on my mind as well. I have seen some of the primitive recordings that the shuttle was able to capture. Having been alive during the end of the Third Great War, officially the bloodiest of the Seven Great Wars, I must say that the brutality we saw among these primitives is stunning, to say the least." She curled her lips slightly as she spoke, possibly to accentuate her haughty expression.

"Actually... as the resident historian, I... I have a question that is bearing on my mind." The forth Founder, Cuanali, the quietest of the Founders to be sure, tapped her fingers rhythmically on the table as she spoke. "It... well, I expect that Founder Unarin has already thought of it, being the oldest, but, ah, well..." She trailed off. It's not that she appeared to be nervous, she simply had a hard time keeping her thoughts straight as she spoke, and had a very erratic way of speaking.

"Something I must have thought of? This is no time for riddles, Cuanali, speak up about your concerns." Unarin gently, but firmly, coaxed her into speaking. None of the Founders were related to each other in any way due to how they had been formed separately, but he still considered the other Founders to be brothers and sisters, as it were.

"Well, it is with regards to the original homeworld. Not Volgarius as we are on now, but err, Volgarius... Alpha, I suppose? You know, we never did give it or this one a proper name..."

Unarin sighed. "Curses, I should have thought more carefully. You have a tendency to let secrets slip when you shouldn't."

Elder Nufaris glanced around at the Founders, who now appeared to be mumbling amongst themselves. "I beg forgiveness for interrupting but... first planet? Volgarius Alpha? W-what might this be about?"

Dosena sighed as she rolled her eyes. "Now you've done it, Cuanali. You just blabbed top secret information regarding events that took place during the Great Wars. Unarin's going to take your head off at this rate, if I don't first."

Cuanali paused as her eyes stared at the table in front of her, flicking left and right as they emptily searched the plain emptiness of the table for nothing in particular. "Ah, well that is to say... I probably shouldn't have mentioned it, but the Elder may know something we need, and we can always mind-wipe him if needed, so, I don't see the ah, problem."

Unarin shifted slightly in his seat. "Yes, I suppose that is a good point. Very well. I had forgotten about the days of the Dark Order, so it can't hurt to bring that stuff up now if the Elder will forget it by tomorrow anyway."

Unarin glanced back at Elder Nufaris. "Nufaris, about that planet you found. Cuanali has reminded me that eons ago, there was a certain *project* we created to save the planet we Volgrim originated on. Well, I shouldn't say *project*, it was more of a multiple-pronged series of projects. And I have reason to believe the planet in the Sector 16, Point 402 void was a result of one of those projects. To be blunt, those life-forms are some form of Volgrim from a long, long past era. They still somewhat resemble us based upon scans of their body structure, but make no mistake, they are no longer a species similar to our own. They have been separated for far too long."

Nufaris almost gasped aloud at this news. "T-they are Volgrim?! That can't be! Look at their technology! Even if they branched off a million orbits ago, or ten million orbits ago, they still are far too undeveloped!"

Dosena raised a single eyebrow. "Possibly." The Founders ignored Nufaris' outburst, that much was to be expected upon hearing not one, but two instances of planet-shattering news in such a small period of time. "They were primitive when you came upon them, however, is it not possible that under the surface of the planet, they might be hiding vast weapon reserves that can fight in void warfare? Is it not possible that their primitive aspects are a necessary distraction to lure other Volgrim into a sense of complacency? I find the idea that it was a trap compelling, as should you, Elder Nufaris. After all, if you fell for a trap, that would be different from directly disobeying a direct order, would it not?"

Dosena stared at him knowingly, and Elder Nufaris nodded slowly. "Y-yes, Founder Dosena. I believe that would be different."

During all of this time, Cinculu the fifth had been totally silent, but he roused himself to speak at this latest exchange. "Personally, I am of the opinion that we should mind-wipe Nufaris, but forgive him of treason. Throughout this exchange, I have seen no reason to believe that he acted out of malice. However, the existence of 'Earth' must be kept a secret, far above the clearance levels of his crew. I advise a mind-wipe for all crewman and himself up to the expedition point of three rotations before they arrived at Earth, along with a formal pardon for the charge of treason. They have provided us diligently with valuable data on fifty other star systems during their unusually long voyage, and one can hardly fault them for making a small mistake at the very end of their journey."

Unarin smiled slightly for once, something he was not often prone to doing. "Cinculu, always the straight-talker. So reliable, brother. I agree with his judgement. Are you three in agreement, or are there any objections?"

The other three Founders nodded in the affirmative, but naturally Dosena had one last thing to say. "I would advise against a straight mind-wipe. Download their memories into the CORE under the highest level authorization. We may glean useful information for the collective of our species, and losing that information would be a shame."

Unarin nodded, as did the other Founders. "Excellent. The meeting is adjourned. Elder Nufaris, I trust you will consent to the mind-wipe without resistance?"

Nufaris nodded quickly as a pained smile took over his face. "I wish to thank all of the Founders today for their wise and compassionate decision. I contemplate, and I comprehend the wisdom you have displayed today."

The founders tilted their heads ever so slightly. "This is not a punishment, rather, it is a reward. For the benefits you have given to the collective good of our species over your short lifespan, you have proven yourself to be a dependable explorer. We will be looking to you in the future as you undoubtedly rise through the ranks."

Nufaris stifled a huge smile as he stood up from his chair gracefully. "Good day, Founders."

Part 231a:

Gregory stood on the opposite side of the hangar, watching as the massive assembly machine slowly lifted the final armored plate on top of the new dreadnought-class battleship. This prototype, unlike the other ships of the past, was designed and built by humans wholly without my help.

It's been a year since my encounter with the Volgrim. Thanks to my abilities, I've built up one heck of a fleet for fighting them if it comes to war, but it drains my energy to have to focus on these things so much. Now that humanity has started building up their own factories, I don't have to work night and day building ships for us to use, and should something happen to me, humanity still has a way to defend themselves.

This first ship they built, especially, was quite the project. Instead of starting small with a prototype, they cheated and used me to perfect the design. The Dreadnought-class ship is quite huge, roughly 70% the size of the Mothership length and width-wise, but it's much 'flatter' meaning that while the mothership has around 5 stories of depth, the Dreadnought only has two.

All the countries in the world have indeed stopped their wars and petty conflicts, once they saw footage of my discussion with the Volgrim. The Volgrim's terrifying appearance were quite the motivator. People don't take kindly to a thing with teeth like a shark and beady little eyes like some villain from a cartoon. My biggest fear is... what if diplomacy doesn't work? Doubtless, the Volgrim will return. Hopefully they will return on a positive note and give us a chance to work things out, but I'm beginning to have doubts.

Everything is falling into place a bit too conveniently. I'm beginning to wonder if I am changing the future, or repeating it. Since I have yet to live through it, it could go either way, and this is what fills me with doubt.

As the crew below welds the new hardened armor onto the Dreadnought, a wave of cheering and yelling goes up around the hangar. This, at the least, is a huge win for humanity. When this prototype successfully launches, we will have two warships in orbit and will begin mass-production.

But that's not all, Japan has also started creating a fully-compliant 'stupid' AI that follows any order given and doesn't tend to think outside of the box. This AI is the one that I believe will end up running the micro-dreadnoughts I faced in the future, but seeing as they are likely going to be the key to winning this war, along with enhanced battle armor and things of that sort, I'm

not going to try and stop their development. They may end up forming into UMI, but that can't be helped. I'll try and stop them if that happens.

As I think these thoughts, I get a communication inside my helmet from a man I designated my secretary. "Judicator, there's a woman here to speak with you. She says it's top priority, but I couldn't find any indication of her identity. Shall I let her in?"

"Sure thing, Thomas. Send her to my office."

Sigh. You know, I'm beginning to miss the simple days of the labyrinth. Even running Hero City was never this intense. I used to have fun all the time, I was able to really enjoy using my abilities, and I guess when it finally comes down to the nail I will eventually get to fight someone again in this time period... I just can't remember when I started looking forwards to battle so much.

Making my way down the various halls, occasionally teleporting around to speed up my ascent, I arrive on the top floor of my underground complex, the ground level introductory section. Walking past a few keycard junctions, I finally arrive at my office and see a beautiful looking young woman sitting on a chair, fidgeting nervously. While my helmet is closed, I quickly cast *Identify* and find that her name is Rachael Donovan, age 27. She has long auburn hair, and she's wearing a white summer dress, along with a small set of glasses for seeing distances. She looks to be a civilian, but *Identify* only tells me a name of an individual along with some pertinent biological information, it's quite useless for finding out background info on a person.

She quickly turns her head as I walk in the room and my mouth-visor slides open. "Rachel Donovan, nice to meet you." I prevent a grin from escaping as her expression turns to slight confusion of how I knew her name.

"A pleasure to meet you too, *Jason Hiro*." Now it's my turn to be shocked. She knows my identity?! Who the-

She extends her small feminine hand forwards and I take it, as my own expression of shock quickly vanishes. "Well well well, it seems we're both full of surprises today."

My mouth visor slaps shut as I turn my head away for an instant, and I turn the windows opaque and disable the security cameras in my room. Before I turn back to look at her, my mouth-visor slides back open and I smile slightly as I walk over to the other side of my reddened mahogany desk and take a seat in my luxurious office chair. Reaching up, I lift off my helmet for the first time in over a year as I rub my blonde hair around. Hmm? Blonde? Didn't I change it to auburn just yesterday? Man, my hair really likes to change back to its original color when I'm not looking.

I lean back in my seat and take her in quickly. She's very short, only about 5'4", and appears to be wearing a wedding band of some sort. She has small petite lips and a fairly unpronounced nose as well. Clearly she takes good care of her looks. I wouldn't be shocked to find out she was a J.C. Penny fashion model of some sort now or in the past.

"So, miss Donovan, what can I help you with today?"

Her eyes glance at my face as she takes my appearance in. "You look different. The file I was shown showed a totally different face, but the hair is the right color."

"Oh, ah, plastic surgery. So who are you, and why do you know my identity, especially that I am also the Judicator?"

She pauses for a moment, as if to think carefully about my question and how to respond, before she continues. "Are you familiar with the Supernatural Protection Force?"

I evenly stare at her for a split second before slowly nodding. "...Yes..." My voice trails off as I wait for her to explain.

"I work for the SPF. One of my fellow agents there, Marie Becker, had this odd conspiracy theory for a long time that she kept going on and on about. I didn't believe her at first... but after much investigation, I had to believe her."

My eyes narrowed as I felt the tiniest tinge of anger in my voice. " *Go on.* "

Rachael appears to be slightly flustered by how little I'm talking. Normally I might find this to be cute, but right now I'm very worried about her words. "W-well, you see, I've been doing a lot of looking around, ah, talking to people who know things, you know, and I found a lot of stuff out that I couldn't believe might be true, and um... well, to tell you the truth, I came to you because... I believe you."

I felt my jaw loosen slightly. "You... believe me? What do you mean by that? I don't follow."

"Oh, well it's about what you said at the WCN conference. You said you were from the future. I believe you. I'm sure plenty do, but I mean to say that I wholeheartedly believe you. I have... actual evidence that you are from the future." She saw me starting to glare slightly and grew even more flustered. "N-no! I didn't speak to anyone about this! You're the first, I swear!"

"All right, fine. So you have proof that I'm from the future, so what? What does that mean for me?"

Rachael shuffled her feet slightly. "Well, the thing is, I think the evidence I have... you should really see it. I don't know how else to put this, but you need to come with me and see for yourself. To say it is a matter of life and death is a gross underestimation."

This woman seems so sure of what she's saying. "I've never met you before. How can I trust you are who you say you are? What if this is a trap?"

She shrugs slightly, her shoulders slumping back down. "I... guess you just have to trust me? I don't really have any proof I can show you right now, because I don't want to carry any documents on me in case I were to get arrested or taken away to a black site on the way here."

I nod slightly, giving up in defeat. "All right, fine. Where do we have to go then?"

* * *

Using the teleporter on board the Mothership in orbit over Earth, we go directly from my office to a set of coordinates in Colorado, not far from my home town. We appear in the middle of a mountain range, directly in front of a massive steel door.

Rachael seems noticeably enthralled by the act of teleportation. "Wow, this is just like in the Star Wars TV show!"

"Star *Trek*." I say, correcting her.

"Right. Sorry, I didn't watch much of it."

"I believe that." I say this flatly as I eyeball the door. After a few seconds, the elation of teleporting has worn off and she quickly pitter-patters over to the door by walking the few feet down the dirt path. Pressing a concealed side panel, some numerical buttons pop out as she types a series of numbers. I memorize them, just in case. *4, 8, 15, 16, 23, 42*. Might be useful to know in case she traps me in here or something.

The big door slowly opens up, lifting up into the mountainside above it. When it's fully open, she beckons for me to follow her, and I do.

We enter into a small narrow hallway, and she pauses. "I don't want anyone else coming in, so I'm going to close the door, alright?"

I nod. "Sure thing." I'm carrying my helmet with me in case I get ambushed and have to use Wordsmithing in a hurry. As she turns back to press the numbers to close the door, I tap my foot slightly, and then just like that, it's over. I watch the door as it closes to make sure nobody else slips in. I mentally confirm with Harold that if need be, even underground, he can teleport me out of here, before I follow along with her.

Interestingly, we walk for almost 10 straight minutes down this long, steel hallway, only slightly illuminated by small lights, and as we walk I can feel a gradual downward descent. We appear to have walked about a mile underground inside this mountain, and truth be told, we're only about a hundred miles away from my own underground base. What could possibly be underground that she is so desperately trying to hide?

Rachel walks very close beside me as we go along, and when I raise an eyebrow and glance at her, she awkwardly takes a step back. "S-sorry, I'm just... a little afraid of the dark." She nudges her glasses up her nose slightly as she stares at the ground. This is slightly awkward, but kind of adorable too.

We arrive at the end of the hallway after about 12 minutes of walking, and are greeted by a long steel door. I begin to feel apprehension, not due to the door, but due to a familiar feeling coming from within the room. "Why are there... dampeners... inside this room? To prevent the use of magic?"

She quickly shakes her head. "No, actually, you have to understand, Jason... I'm not hiding this from anyone in particular, I'm hiding it from *everyone at once*, human, demon, and angel alike. I will be lucky if I'm only fired over this. I could lose my life over what I've done."

I can feel a bit of apprehension in my gut, but I only nod as she again types in a long series of numbers, swipes a keycard twice, opens her eye for a retinal scan, and finally uses a fingerprint. Goddamn, she's not kidding... this place has so many layers of security... what is she hiding in here?

The door opens and the room we enter in is pitch black, but it feels small. This is perhaps the size of a storage shed... but inside the room, there's a very familiar glow. A light blue glow is coming from a single small light source, up towards the ceiling that is merely 8 feet high.

This glow... I recognize it. It's from the light on top of a cryopod.

"Jason... meet, uh... Jason." Rachael beckons towards the cryopod as she walks in, shining a light on it.

A chill freezes my body, from the skin all the way down to the bone. Inside the cryopod, I see a very familiar looking face sleeping silently. It's my own face. This is... me?

"What... the... hell..."

Part 232a: Tear

"I hope you understand now." Rachael spoke softly as I slowly placed my hand on the unbelievably cold surface of the cryopod. My gloves, reinforced with incredible amounts of magic, still let plenty of the cold in, so I pulled it back quickly.

"No... no I don't understand. I don't understand anything. Who the hell is this? I never got in the cryopod. I was supposed to, but I didn't. This can't be me."

"I think you are correct, but you need to understand the circumstances, and how I came to find this cryopod. It all started a couple years ago... the day we brought you in for questioning at the SPF headquarters."

* * *

"Rachel, give me that readout. I want numbers, hard numbers." Jamal swirled over on his wheeled office-chair as he bounced from desk to desk. "What was the reading on that energy signature?"

Rachel hurriedly glanced at it, as her face whitened slightly. "T-type three! We've got a Washington!"

"What? Type three? Are you absolutely sure? Is it confirmed on COMSTAT?" Jamal fired off a barrage of questions as he surged back over to his own desk, typing hurriedly at his six-monitor PC as he glanced from screen to screen.

"COMSTAT? Yeah, they have it, so does our guy at NORAD. Harris at the ATF too."

"Locations, Rachel! Give me coordinates!" Jamal grabbed the phone as his hand shook with anticipation, nearly dropping it out of his hand. "Hamilton, get Director Marie up here, pronto. She HAS to see this. *Yes*, it's a code Washington."

"I knew today would be the day, but I didn't expect..." Rachel whispered to herself as she typed furiously. "Got it, location is Colorado, mid sized town in the middle of bumfuck nowhere." She fired off some coordinates as Jamal slammed the phone down and started typing furiously.

"Is that a residence? Find out the exact flashpoint location, then get Agent J on the line. I want boots on the ground!"

Rachel nodded furiously as she quickly typed out a summary of data for Jamal to send to the ground squad. She pulled up records on the building's layout as well as its current residents,

noting it was a very low rent slum-like building. She found 5 tenants under the age of 20, and one of them just happened to have a birthday today.

"I've got a match, boss. Blondie, age 18, matches the profile."

Jamal wheeled over slightly to get a look at the picture. "Jason *Hiro*? Damn, his parents sound presumptuous. Is the flashpoint a match?"

Rachel checked the coordinates. "...Floor 2, room 3, yep. That's our man."

"Bring up the street cameras. Get a satellite over the area. I want to know where he's going before *he* knows. I'll let Mr. Rothschild know about this in an hour too, just in case."

"Right, I'm on it." Rachel felt her entire body trembling. This was it... after 5 years on the task force, she was about to finally see all their efforts bear fruit. She would finally be able to see a candidate in person, get to see what all the hype was about.

"Rachel, you stay here in comms. I'm heading out with the team." Jamal stood up, grabbing his uniform as he walked away.

"What? I'm not going? But you said-!"

Jamal closed the door behind himself, ignoring her words as he charged out the door.

Rachel slumped into her chair as she stared at the readouts on her screen. "Fine, whatever, asshole. I guess being the *boss* means you get to have all the fun." She rolled her eyes as she leaned back in and started reading what little information there was on this Jason kid.

* * *

A few hours later, her camera feed for Interrogation Room 5C came online as she flicked it into focus. Having just received notification that the candidate was soon to arrive, she stared at the screen intently, as she sipped on a mango smoothie one of the 'suits' had dropped off at her request. Being in comms had few perks, but being on a level technically above them and being able to order them around was... *kind of fun*.

Kicking her feet back and forth, her heart skipped a beat as the Jason kid ambled into the room. "Oooh! He's here! He's here!" She yelled to nobody in particular, as the room was totally empty aside from herself. Comms was a small division, but critical for monitoring during times when flashpoints were expected.

She grimaced as she saw the camera switch for a moment to the monitoring area behind the one-way mirror, showing Jamal and a few of the suits talking and having a good time. *Probably making bets about what his abilities will be, if it really is him*. Rachel sighed as she leaned back into her chair and stared at the screen emptyly.

The young man on the screen fidgeted and looked extremely uncomfortable. "You've got to be kidding? This is the legendary candidate I've heard so much about? He looks like a string-bean!" Rachel yelled out loud in exasperation, knowing full well nobody could hear her.

* * *

Some time passed, and finally Marie, who had been standing on the other side of the glass for ten minutes, simply staring at the young man in the room, finally entered. *God, she's so cold. She waited just to draw out the wait and make him uncomfortable. She learned from the best when it comes to interrogations.* Rachel observed the interaction with disinterest. This kid couldn't be the candidate. He was too weak, just so utterly weak.

The kid stuttered and stammered on the screen as Marie drilled him, just like she always did to POWs and suspected terrorists, or other enemies of the state nobody would ever miss if they went missing. This job had its dark sides, and sometimes those days grated on Rachel's conscience, but right now, all she felt was boredom.

And then something interesting happened. Marie called the guards in, and as she did, the kid, clearly flustered, yelled "STOP!" at the top of his lungs. As he did, a massive spike in Type 3 energy screamed onto the scanner in the Comms center. Rachel nearly jumped out of her seat at the sudden wailing. *Holy shit! It really is him! That kid is the candidate!*

The energy died down just as quickly as it had come. A few minutes later, the scanner was totally silent. Rachel's heart pounded in her chest. Just as she was about to finally calm herself down and lean back in her chair, *another* tremendous spike of energy lit up on all the scanners.

On the edge of her seat, Rachel quickly checked its location, only to be confused. There were actually two energy signals, one inside the cell where the kid was being held, and another over a hundred miles away.

Rachel stared at the screen, tapping buttons. Narrowing the location down, she found that the second signal was somewhere in a facility owned by CryoTek, a new startup from a few years ago that had placed ads in local newspapers allowing people to freeze their bodies to live into the distant future.

Her confusion seemed to dissipate as she considered what this meant. *Did we miss something? Are there two candidates all of a sudden? I should call Jamal and tell him about this.*

She reached for her radio and stopped. Staring at the readouts on her screen, she bit her lip as she thought about what this meant. Once again, Jamal would go and get to have all the fun. *To hell with that.* She glanced around at the monitors, which showed people watching the struggle inside the Interrogation Room with much interest.

Acting on impulse, her fingers flicked over the keyboard, quickly deleting all traces of the detection of type 3 energy. Making sure she left nothing behind, she resumed staring at the screen.

Twenty minutes later, Jamal creaked open the door to the office as he stepped in, chatting on his phone. "Thanks, Mrs. Harris. Yeah, we think it's him. Alright, talk later, tell Jim I said hi. Uh-huh. No problem. B-" He started to say 'bye' but the line clicked. He shrugged. "She's really not one for long goodbyes."

Rachel's heart started racing as he plopped down into his seat and spun around once, rubbing his hands on his bald-shaven head. "Yooo Rachel. Anything CRAZY happen while I was gone? Because that was pretty exciting, I think."

Rachel's heart slowed as she grasped what he meant. *Great, he's here to brag and rub it in.* "No, it was boring here. I see you got to have fun though."

"Hell yeah I did! You should have seen the look on his FACE when we pulled him in the van! He was like a deer in the headlights!" Jamal gloated as he grinned, using his usual manner of exaggeration to explain how awesome and exciting his life was.

Rachel rolled her eyes as she performed her usual routine of pretending not to care, but in fact she really truly did not actually care this time. "That's great, Jamal. Just fantastic. Since you're here, mind if I check out for the day? If you get to have the fun, I get to go home and nap, alright?"

Jamal grinned eagerly. "Ha! You're jealous, I can tell! Suck it up, buttercup, don't get your panties in a twist!"

"Jamal, that's sexual harassment." Rachel smirked as his own smile faded slightly. "Don't make me call HR."

"HR my ass, get out of here and go play with your dolls. The big boy has got this on LOCK!" Jamal's grin returned as he smirked and rolled over to his computer, bringing up Youtube to watch some stupid videos about his favorite memes.

"Yeah... I'll do that. See you later, *boss.*" Rachel rolled her eyes again, as he responded with a quick wave.

The two of them butted heads, but it was mostly all fun.

As Rachel stepped out of the Comms office and walked down the halls, her heart quickened again as she drew nearer and nearer to the parking garage where her Lexus was parked.

*Jesus Christ, what am I doing? I deleted government information, at a **black site** no less. This is treason of the highest degree. I'll be lucky if I just face prison time. If I return and they*

have seen **anything** wrong with the recent timestamps... I have no alibi.

No... no it's too late now. I've already deleted the information. This can't be undone. I might as well move on with what I'm doing. I see no way this ends with a success or good news, but it's too late to turn back now.

She clicked open her Lexus with the unlock button, stepped inside, and fired up the engine. It made a soft purring sound as she backed out of her spot and drove around the garage.

Treason. I'm about to guarantee myself a spot at the top of America's Most Wanted list. This had better be worth it.

Rachel drove down the road away from the Black Site, finally entering a normal highway, as she sped off into the distance.

* * *

Arriving at CryoTek, she parked a few blocks away, though if the government wanted to track her, they'd easily find her regardless of where she parked. She had seen enough of the NSA files on citizens to know how far down everyone's throat they were. Their facial recognition technology had a 99.6% accuracy rating too, which was two percentage points higher than a human trying to recognize their own siblings or parents.

Putting on a wide-brimmed sun hat, Rachel started walking the few blocks towards Cryotek. She kept her head down, knowing that nearly every traffic light in America had already been bugged in such a way that she could be tracked anywhere she went, if the government so wanted. Her paranoia was high, but in the end, there was no surefire protection against the long arm of Uncle Sam.

Arriving at CryoTek, Rachel walked slowly down the corridors, taking her time as she walked right past the reception desk. She arrived at a door barring her from entering a location in the building due to a keypad lock.

Well, best to do things the bold way. Turning back, she walked up to the front desk and saw a man sitting there, apparently he was the receptionist. "Excuse me, my name is Rachel Donovan, and I work for the government. Could you point me in the direction of whoever is the manager on duty here?"

The young man behind the desk eyed her up and down for a second, as she pulled out an official-looking badge and flashed it at him. Taking a split-second to glance at it, clearly not reading into it too deeply, he nodded silently. Reaching over, he tapped a few buttons on the phone.

"Director Comoye? We've got a lady here to speak with you, works for the feds. No sir, she has no appointment. All right, yes, I understand. So sorry to bug you about this, sir."

Hanging up the phone quickly, he beckoned towards the other hallway, leading down the edge of the building. "Go down this way, walk past three doors, and you'll be at the elevator. Use the passcode '1623' and it will take you right to the main office. Please be quick, Comoye is a very busy man."

"Don't worry, this will only take a moment." Rachel smiled sweetly at the young man, as he blushed slightly and looked away. She still had it, the ability to make young men smitten head over heels for her charms.

Turning around, she headed down the hallway towards Comoye's office.

* * *

"After that, I met with the director and explained some things that needed explaining, but I didn't go into much detail. Actually, I told him that I had suspicions a youth on the run from the Government may have put himself in suspended animation, and I simply wanted to run an identity check. What I found... was this."

Rachel beckoned at the cryopod and my eyes followed her hands. "So... what is it? Who is this? He can't be *me*."

She paused. "I believe... he is from an alternate universe. One that converged at some sort of Novikov Point within our own universe. Perhaps he is from an original universe, and he merged into ours when you performed some specific action, or perhaps due to someone else's interference he was brought into our universe. I don't know, but what I do know is that he arrived here through a similar method that you did."

I stared at the frozen man in front of me. A stupid idea of thawing him out swept through my mind, but I decided against it. "You did the right thing, by coming to me. I don't know what I'll do, but for now, I'll take him to the safest point in the entire solar system."

Saying that, I turned my attention to Harold in my mental vision. "Did you catch all that, Harold?"

"Sure did! You're such an interesting feller, why didn't ya tell me ye had a twin?! I'd have liked to meet him 'fore they put him on ICE! Bahahaha!"

"Great. Bring all three of us up there, and I'll get to attaching the cryopod inside the Mothership."

I paused and waited as Harold made the necessary calculations. Surprisingly, even this deep in the mountains, it was a piece of cake for him to calculate transport to the ship. In the blink of

an eye, Rachel and I were inside my personal Mothership, and the Cryopod was ripped out of its energy holders, the lights shutting off. At his current temperature, it'd be a few hours before the body thawed to any harmful levels, but still... I quickly put my helmet on, closing the mouth-visor shut as Rachel gaped at the splendor of my Mothership. Speaking quickly, I build a containment room shielded by dozens of layers of metal and magic, then placed the Cryopod inside that room, attaching it to the power cables.

Taking a deep breath from the energy I expended, I quickly removed the helmet again. Rachel hardly even seemed to notice I was there anymore, as she wandered all about the hangar bay we had entered into. Over a hundred large ships were laying here and there, and she seemed fascinated by each and every one.

Seems Rachel has a lot to learn about Earth's resistance effort.

"Rachel, are you able to return to the black site?"

She shrugged. "Even if I could, I don't really want to. I'm not so sure they were the 'good guys' anymore."

I chuckled. "In my experience, there is no such thing as good or bad... only how the self interests of one person or another bubble up to the surface... and some people are far more despicable than others."

I reached my hand out to her. "Welcome to the United Earth Forces. Glad to have you aboard."

She rolled her eyes at my hand, but reached over and shook it gently. "You men and your theatrics."

Part 233a:

Thanksgiving, 2024.

"Thank you, Mr. President."

I smile as President Steven Johannesburg, now two years into his second term, slides a saucer of gravy over to me. Taking the saucer by its handle, I pour a decent amount of gravy on my mashed potatoes. Reaching to my side, I pick up a spoon and dig in to the delicious soft and fluffy potatoes, occasionally also taking a stab at the yams or taking a bite of a croissant. I felt a sharp revulsion earlier when they brought out the turkey, but I managed to hide my disgust by reminding myself that *it's not chicken at least*.

I'm eating at a white house luncheon for various world leaders. Even North Korea's new leader, Sarah Mc'fallaneux is here. She of course was instated to run its government following the 'liberation' shortly after the 2016 elections, but that's a story for another day. It must be quite interesting to have a woman ruling over the country after so many years of dictator-like men, though it has to be an improvement for the general citizenry.

President Johannesburg smiles as he taps his wine glass with a knife and stands up at his seat. All hundred or so eyes in the room turn towards him and conversations cut off as people look on in interest.

"My fellow Americans, Canadians, Britons, and so on... I want to thank you all for attending this Thanksgiving feast, on the 403rd anniversary of its first occasion. I also want to extend a special thanks to our honored guest, who goes by the name of Judicator. Thanks to his guidance and leadership, the world has entered a unified state of governing where we can all work together to advance the fate of humanity towards a more positive future."

The crowd applauded politely as he continued on. "Truly, this is more than just a historic day of giving thanks for all the good things we are blessed with. Humanity stands on a precipice, where only a few years ago we would have faced the potential of total annihilation. But, thanks to the efforts of our esteemed guest, we have not only completed the first major base on Mars, we have just launched the first cooperatively made Capital-Class Battleship, the UEF Survival. With a crew of 20,000 women and men, a hangar with over 300 fighter-class ships, and survival gear that could last a millennium without any contact with Earth, this ship is not just a flying armada in and of itself, it represents a final hope for Humanity should the worst occur as Judicator has warned."

"In addition, the underground bases are proceeding steadily. Two thousand have been built across the Earth, having the ability to house ten million registered citizens, considered the best and the brightest of our kind. While I would like to eventually protect all people on Earth, these early measures will allow us to survive, even in the case of the absolutely worst scenario."

The crowd applauded mightily, and even I felt myself clapping jubilantly.

"While we may prepare for dark times, we have much to be thankful for. We will not go out quietly into the night, we will mount a resistance that time itself will remember, should things come to the worst. But I have faith... I have faith in Judicator. He has delivered to us technology that should not exist for another hundred years, perhaps even a thousand years. With a man like this on our side, there is no challenge too great, no mountain too tall, no river too wide that we cannot ford. I have faith not just in this great man, but also the people of my nation, and the people of yours, that when the hammer strikes the gong, and the moment of truth is upon us, we will rise up and face it head-on, as humanity has always done."

The entire crowd roared with applause, many people looking over at me with big smiles on their face. I clapped as well, keeping my own expression to a neutral tight smile.

"Things are looking up. Tomorrow, we announce to the citizens of the world the L.I.F.E. project, a massive dome-like ship that will be built in Argentina, which will launch six years from now, and will allow one million people to live inside of it, traveling the cosmos, looking in search of another inhabitable world outside our solar system. Next year we will announce the initial construction of "Cathedral", a joint national project looking to be built in Spain."

Johannesburg paused for a second as he fumbled with his notes slightly.

"In any case, things are looking up, and-" As he spoke, I suddenly received a communication from Harold.

I jumped to my feet as I received the news, causing people near me to jolt back in fright and the President to halt his speech. "The party is over. Earth is under attack."

A shock ran through the crowd as wrist communicators suddenly started lighting up and the various dignitaries received their first mental communications from their varying home countries. The new MIND communicators so far worked perfectly, though we were testing them with those in the upper class first due to their prohibitive cost associations.

"The Volgrim! A surprise attack!" Prime Minister Gerald S. Bonaparte of the British Alliance quickly made his way from his chair, heading for the exit. "Commander Beatrix is up there by herself! Get your ships to the Moon-side of the planet, that's where they're ambushing us from!"

I felt a cold chill go down my spine as I received the damage reports. A surprise attack? An ambush? Why?

From outside the White House, there was an explosion and a few people screamed, as the windows in the room suddenly exploded inwards. In the blink of an eye, using my superior thinking speed, I aimed my hand at the windows, using my innate telekinesis powers to halt the glass before it could reach anyone. In the next instant, I let it fall and crash to the floor harmlessly.

The lights to the room went out all at the same time, as if the power had been cut by an outside force. As I took notice of this development, I witnessed several shadowy forms barge through the windowsill and start charging the dignitaries.

So they want to fight in the dark, huh? That's fine... *I like the dark.*

Part 234a:

"Harold. Activate Lightning Mode."

I spoke mentally to him, as the shadowy forms entered the room. In the blink of an eye, I felt my suit's primary systems come online all at once. "You got it, boss! Heh heh heh!"

I swiveled my head to the side, noticing that my body had become completely invisible. My mouthpiece slid shut as I jumped into the air, burying my hand into the ceiling with a single punch as my radar systems tracked the movement of every hostile entity in the room. Curiously, I noted these appeared to not be Volgrim, they looked like they were human, but I suspected they might be demon. I'd have to tell in a few minutes.

My suit activated a series of neutralization lasers, firing at several hostiles at once, instantly severing their heads from their bodies, the lasers moving too fast to even be seen. A moment later, the few remaining invaders yelped as their allies toppled over, headless.

With their initial infiltrators in confusion, I jammed my feet against the ceiling, letting go with my hand, and using my suit's compressed leg power to dash at the ground a couple dozen feet below me faster than a speeding bullet, as I aimed my body at another hostile.

He never saw it coming. Neither did his friends.

He exploded into a mass of blood and sinewy veins as his body transformed into a puddle in the blink of an eye. My suit of course, took absolutely no damage. I've been reinforcing it with every spell I can think of, increasing its speed, its flexibility, its regenerative abilities... at this point I'm pretty sure a nuclear bomb wouldn't leave a dent, though I have yet to try that.

His friend had barely even started to register the mess to his right side before I yanked out my hand and pulled him towards me with telekinetic abilities. When his neck met my hand, I squeezed and his mouth let out no noise other than an eerie *gurgle* as his head popped off, showering the room in blood.

One more to go. One of the invaders was dashing towards the window, terror in his eyes as he had seen every one of his comrades get felled in a spectacular display of battle prowess. To be honest, I'm not sure how much of my battle ability was me, and how much was the suit, though my twelve years in the labyrinth surely couldn't have hurt.

I jumped at him with a pitifully small amount of effort, grabbing him by the shirt as my mouth-piece popped open. "Where do you think *you're* going?"

The person jerked his head around, revealing a head full of sharp teeth. Wait, he is a Volgrim? "Self-destruct!"

As he said that, my suit registered an explosion occurring in his body, instantly snapping my mouth-cover shut and making my hand snap open as my palm deployed a forward facing wide-angled force field. In the next instant, his body exploded in a fiery burst, as did the bodies of his companions behind me.

The blast was massive, much bigger than I expected, engulfing the entire room in flame. I jerked my head back to see several dignitaries fly towards the other side of the room, as they had been caught in the explosion.

All of this, from the moment of the invaders' entrance, had taken a mere twenty-five seconds. Hardly any foreign dignitaries had evacuated the room.

Bodies lay everywhere, in heaps and crumples. President Johannesburg lay a few feet away from me, his body fried to a crisp. Those bombs... they were not normal bombs. They burned at nearly three thousand degrees, hot enough to melt steel beams, yet left no residual fires after the initial explosion. They were like... a bio-bomb of some sort.

Naturally, I was not harmed in the slightest. My sensors indicated my suit had yet to take even a single percentage worth of damage... but excluding the invader bodies... there were ninety-four corpses in the room. Ninety-four dead dignitaries and foreign leaders.

"Jesus Christ... this is... a declaration of all-out war." I mumbled to myself. Detecting some life forms moving away from the room, I took note of their unique DNA identifiers, noting that the prime minister of Britain had survived, as well as the current leader of Egypt, and a few others. In total, only a dozen guests had survived.

But... I can't take time to focus on these bodies. They will have to wait. I have a space battle to win.

"Harold. Get me up there."

"Working on it! Give me a second, goddamn whippersnapper!" His voice sounded strained, as he was guiding the Mothership through the field of battle and running the entire ship all by himself.

A few seconds later, my body de-materialized and re-materialized as I appeared in the Mothership.

Carnage. Absolute carnage. Everywhere that I could see, wreckage from this fierce battle was left over, floating in space.

At the front of the ship, towards the direction of the Moon, I spotted over a hundred Capital-Class warships, owned by the Volgrim. Massive ships that my scanners indicated had tens of thousands of crew members on-board. Our own ships were pitiful compared to these, but even they paled in comparison to the Volgrim flagship.

The flagship was massive, on a scale unbelievable to man. It must have been the size of one of the smaller U.S. states, like Rhode Island. I detected a ridiculous number of life signs on board, close to 500,000.

"This is David versus Goliath. They came prepared too." I spoke to nobody in particular as I aimed my hand at the capital ship. " **EXPLODE!** "

I detected a tiny explosion on board the ship, but it seemed to do very little to the ship. It would take a massive amount of energy to destroy it with my current power, and the container at my waist that I had once again refilled over the last few years was not meant for this. I'd only use it in the case of a true emergency, but for now, I'd have to do this myself.

"Harold, beam me aboard the flagship. Anywhere will do, but closer to the center is better."

"Whoa there, kid! I know yer strong, but that's beyond risky! We need ye on board to order the fleet around!" He mentally indicated our own ships getting shredded.

I shook my head. "Beatrix is the one I deemed most capable. She can handle this. If she gives you any orders, and she probably won't, make sure to follow them. I'm going there, solo. I'm needed there."

Harold sighed. "Alright, kid. Just... don't get yerself killed out there."

I rolled my eyes slightly. "Harold, I'm inside a virtually indestructible super-suit. YOU are the one in the most danger. If this ship is destroyed, I'll have to rescue you in outer space and that does not sound fun. Don't die, alright?"

Harold smirked in my vision as he sat on his rocking chair. "Smarmy little cunt, ain'tcha? I fought in World War II, this ain't nothing. Git outta here, kid. I got this under control."

I nodded as I aimed my hand at their ship. Focusing on the force-field surrounding the ship, I spoke a single word.

" *Gap.* "

A gap opened in their force-field, as Harold beamed me inside... into the underbelly of the beast.

Part 235a:

Ancient Lunaris surveyed the battlefield coldly, her lack of emotions apparent to all on the bridge. Naturally, the majority of Volgrim held no ability to communicate emotionally, but some could express forms of fondness for those they had grown close to in some fashion or another. Lunaris was unable to form even a drop of anger, sadness, happiness, or any other such emotion, having shut them out in her quest to someday become the 6th Founder.

However, Ancient Lunaris was one of the oldest of her kind, having lived for at least a few hundred thousand orbits, though she was still young compared to the Founders themselves. A direct subordinate of Founder Dosena, the second ranked, she had fought in every war starting with the Third Great War of their kind, and now she was to begin participation in the Extermination War. If she were able to feel even a drop of emotion, likely she would be exceedingly proud of this moment.

The vermin fell before her like pests under a boot. Outside her ship, she saw a few hundred small warships of varying sizes, all of them minuscule compared to her own Capital-Class warships. To say the least of her personal flagship, the Vindicator. An appropriate name, given the hostile intent these alien species clearly bore towards her people.

A viewscreen appeared before her, as a simulated face began to speak. "Ancient Lunaris, I have detected a minor breach in the shield system. A single life form was able to teleport aboard this vessel you command. Your orders?"

She continued staring ahead, not deigning to look at the new AI that had been installed on the ship. Frankly, she didn't trust it. Only she and the founders were old enough to remember the disaster at the Melkian IV facility, where a rogue AI had exterminated two hundred million Volgrim during the Seventh Great War their people fought, eventually bringing an end to the wars entirely during the signing of the Inter-Communal Anti-Hostility act. Since then, there had been a terse but appreciated peace that followed for over a hundred thousand orbits.

And now she had a sentient AI aboard her vessel. The thought made her skin crawl. "Exterminate it. Send an interception team. We need to focus on the battle."

"I beg your pardon, Ancient one, but this particular life form is-" The AI attempted to speak but Lunaris cut it off.

"AI designated 'Umi', do not question my orders aboard this starship. I am the commander and my orders are absolute."

"Yes, Ancient one. I contemplate, and I comprehend. Sending an interception team now. Do you have any further orders?"

Lunaris glanced at the viewscreen for a moment. "Send squadron Red Tango to the flanking position in section three, target their bombers that are assailing our forward ranks. Then send in Red Retriever along with Blue Stellaris to take out the cannons on those destroyer-class warships. They're wreaking havoc on the artillery units."

"Yes, Ancient one. I am dispatching your orders now." Umi set about relaying the orders to the appropriate squadrons.

Lunaris stared intently at the battle unfolding in front of her. *They are primitives, but they fight with such cunning, such savagery. By contrast our troops have gone far too long without decent training. After we mop up this battlefield, I will have to increase training ten-fold for those who live to fight another day.*

Lunaris stared out the plexi-glass of her flagship, all while a single red dot flashed on a holoscreen off to the side. A single invader was making a mockery of her ship's security teams.

* * *

I dashed forwards, using my telekinesis to shove enemies out of my way, into each other, flinging them up into the air, and occasionally yanking them towards myself for a little close-up barbarism, where fitting.

"Harold. I know you're busy, but can you find the main core for me?" I jumped at an enemy who was training his gun on me. He pulled the trigger, and a hot blast of plasma blasted into my chest, bouncing off like a twig on concrete.

"Yer gonna have to give me a minute kid, I'm a lil' bit busy, yanno!" Harold yelped as a particularly strong cannon salvo slammed into the Mothership. "Jesus jumped up Christ! This is worse'n when the god-dayum Jap's were hailing bullets from above during the Battle of Midway! I wasn't there but shee-oot I heard all 'bout it from the boys when they done got back!"

"That's great, Harold! Let me know when you catch a moment!" I suddenly come to a stop as a group of Volgrim Elites encircles me, each one of them blasting me with everything they've got. Totally ignoring their fire which does literally nothing to my defenses, I use my radar and internal systems to scan all over the place around myself. The ship has numerous 'hot' spots which could be power generators, and some are running a few thousand kelvin, but it's hard to tell which, if any, are the main sources that keep the ship running.

As the enemies unload a hail of fire on me, I swivel towards one of them, who appears to be a leader. "Excuse me! Where is your main power located? Like the main generator for the ship?"

He looks at me in total bewilderment, his face totally aghast that I haven't taken a single bit of damage. "What are you, some kind of monster?! I'd never give up the secrets to an enemy spy!"

I shrug. It was worth a shot. "Alright, if you won't tell me, I'll make you tell me. *Answer*. Where is the shield generator?"

The Volgrim continues firing at me, but his face turns blank for a moment as my wordsmithing does its magic. "Coordinates 2.71, 6.94, and 9.05. There are three main generators that power this ship."

His companions halt their firing on me and quickly whip around to look at their general in shock. As my wordsmithing wears off, his own face blanches as he realizes what he's done. "Y-you! What did you do to me?! I would sooner die than give away Volgrim secret intelligence!"

I shrug again. "Guess you had a change of heart." My mouth-piece slides shut as I aim my mental vision at all the Volgrim surrounding me. " *Eviscerate*. "

They all explode into chunks of flesh as horrific invisible blades shred them into pieces.

Glancing back at my internal HUD, I quickly enter the coordinates I was given, and find that in the Volgrim system of coordinate locating, those are three positions on the ship, corresponding with the front, middle, and rear of the ship. Fantastic, they're all spread out. The biggest issue, however, is the *size* of this ship. At 38 miles long, and 25 miles wide, not to mention 12 miles tall, that is a *lot* of ground to cover in such a short period of time. My scanners linked up to the Mothership indicate that the battle outside is worsening visibly for humanity. At this rate, within the next few hours, our forces will be wiped out, and Earth will be next.

I decide to do my best. Using my innate teleportation abilities, I quickly start leaping forwards, 'jumping' from spot to spot, rapidly covering ground as I head back towards the front of the flagship.

If I can bring this behemoth down, the rest may fall into disarray. If I can't... humanity may come to its end much sooner than anticipated.

Part 236a:

Commander Beatrix stared evenly out at the battlefield, her jaw set hard into its socket.

Things were looking *grim*.

She had started out with a few hundred warships, and a few thousand fighters and bombers. The enemy had started out with twice their numbers in all forms, and their ships were much bigger, tougher, and possessed far more advanced weaponry. To call this a losing battle was the understatement of the century.

Humanity's numbers were down to less than a quarter of their original numbers. The Volgrim however, had lost *less* than a quarter of their entire fighting force.

This wasn't a battle anymore... it was an outright slaughter.

She pulled her wrist communicator up and tapped some buttons quickly. "John, is the prime minister back yet? Are reinforcements on their way?"

The response came back badly garbled, as many of Earth's satellites had been blown out of orbit by stray or aimed shots. "...issues. Leave... to us....stay in formation at all times....may not arrive at all, you're on your own up there....and out."

Beatrix snarled angrily. "Son of a bitch! Nobody's on their way, and we haven't a hope of winning at this point."

She fought back incredible rage as she watched yet another volley obliterate the lives of ten men and women flying around in small fighter ships. Things were absolutely, positively hopeless.

"Commander Beatrix! Judicator's personal ship has hailed us! He was able to sabotage their flagship! It's floating dead in space!"

Beatrix rolled her eyes angrily. "Fantastic! That only leaves two hundred and ninety-three capital ships to shit hell on us! At least the biggest ship will be out of commission for a whole hour if we're lucky!"

As she glared at the space in front of Earth, out towards the moon, she bit her lip as rage filled her mind. *Those sons of bitches think they can take down the Bitch of Britain? Not on this day!*

"Captain, target the ships in the best condition. Tell the crew on all vessels to evacuate to escape pods immediately, then set all of our remaining battlecruisers to initiate lightspeed, aimed directly at their ships. If I'm correct, there will be a spectacular amount of damage on the

battlefield. The debris will make it impossible to ever launch a ship into orbit around Earth ever again, but I refuse to lose this war like this!"

"C-commander! That's suicide! If all of our ships are gone, even if we make this a neutral result where our forces lose as theirs do, the debris will rain down on Earth, killing thousands, millions, maybe even billions! We won't have any ships left to clean up the mess!"

Beatrix turned her fiery red face towards her second in command to issue a strong, angry retort, but at that moment, her communicator lit up. A calm voice spoke in her head, crisp and clear. "Commander Beatrix. My name is Silver. I am a top secret agent working for the U.S. government. Tell all of your ships to divert all power, every last drop, to defensive systems to hold out as long as possible."

"Silver?! I've never heard of you! How did you get on this secure line? I don't take orders from some nobody!" Beatrix glared angrily at her communicator as she yelled.

"Commander, I have bad news. The White House was attacked, and most leaders of the world's nations were killed in a barbaric attack by an unknown third party. My team is currently investigating. I am taking emergency control of the defense forces, by the orders of the highest ranking dignitary left alive, the leader of Egypt, Representative Saburo. And to be clear, you may ignore my orders if you wish, but I cannot guarantee your survival. This is merely a courtesy to try and help as many of our forces survive as possible."

Beatrix's anger dissipated, ever so slightly. "What are we to do while defending? We'll be torn to shreds if we aren't firing back, unless you have a solution that can save us in the next ten minutes!" As she spoke, her entire ship shuddered mightily as a proton missile blasted away the front of her flagship.

"We have a secret weapon. Do whatever you will. It will fire in one minute's time, whether you are ready or not. Good day." The cold sounding voice, almost robotic in its tone, clicked off. Beatrix spent all of two seconds considering what she had just heard before reaching a decision. "Goddamnit! Belay my previous order! Tell all ships to divert 99% of power to the shields and the remaining power to life support! Hold on as long as you possibly can!" Even as she barked the order, another ship was shredded into pieces, exploding in a ball of fire before the vacuum of space quickly sucked it out to nothingness.

* * *

On the surface of Earth, in a bunker deep below a secret base in Nevada, Agent Silver stared at his comms console. "Time to fire, 34 seconds and counting. There's no issue with the transmitter coils, right?"

A man on the other side of the room quickly looked at a data pad and jerked his head back up. "No sir! We fixed that two hours ago!"

"You certainly hope we did." Silver, a 34 year old man of eastern European descent, stroked his small patch of chin hair softly, as he watched the power levels on his screen rapidly rise. 24 seconds left.

The Sword of Damocles, a massive railgun built totally in secret, even from the other nations of the world after the UEF came into existence. It's existence was so secretive that the only way you could know of it was to actively live inside the bunker where it was being built, and you were never allowed to leave. Silver had worked on the weapon for over four years, ever since the first appearance of Judicator, and now today would be the prototype testing phase.

Ten seconds remaining. The sand of the Nevada desert parted unnaturally, as a massive hole opened up in the ground, and a colossal cannon raised up, a spiraling conduit encircling in. The weapon was designed to take a projectile of any size within a certain limit, and fire it at nearly the speed of light. The only downside was that it had a small limit of firing range as far as the area it could target. Luckily, the battle in space happened to be occurring right in that area.

"Ready to launch!" An aide yelled at the top of his lungs.

"Load projectile JM-12. Fire at 10% power. Target the ship at coordinates X:0045B Y:40021J, aim for the dead center of the ship. Let's see how much power the weakest setting can muster."

The aide nodded quickly, pressing the appropriate code to load the first round. After it loaded, he nodded. "Ready!"

Silver turned back to watch his viewscreen, which live-streamed the battle in space from a secret spy satellite installed explicitly for their uses, for targeting enemies within a certain range.

"...Fire!"

* * *

Beatrix watched, her hands shaking uncontrollably, as two more of her ships were blasted to smithereens. Their shields came under a massive barrage, as the enemy suddenly began focus-firing all of their shots one-by-one on each ship, totally overwhelming the shields. There were now only 9 ships left.

"This battle... is over." Beatrix stared numbly at her viewscreen, as the enemies finished off another ship, reducing her numbers to just 8. As their fire turned towards her flagship, she closed her eyes halfway, waiting for the final blow.

And at that instant, all hell broke loose. A massive explosion, the size of twenty Hiroshima nuclear detonations at once, lit up the sky in front of her. In the blink of an eye, one of the capital ships exploded into ten million pieces in a ball of fire so fierce that for a second, it dwarfed the brightness of the sun. Beatrix winced visibly against the intensity of the light.

Just as she opened her eyes to look out the plexi-glass window, another titanic explosion occurred, shredding another capital ship into pieces. For the briefest of seconds, she thought she might have even seen a tiny streak of energy tearing through the void of space before it struck a third capital class ship. What the hell was going on?!

* * *

Ancient Lunaris looked at the spectacle in front of herself in total bewilderment. Not one to show emotions in over a hundred thousand orbits, her jaw hung open, aghast, as five capital ships were shredded within seconds of one another. Just as she was about to speak, a sixth exploded again, blinding her with its incredible flash of light. Not only that, but debris from the ships exploded outwards like massive heavy chunks of shrapnel, tearing into other nearby ships, dealing colossal amount of damage.

"Umi! What is the meaning of this?! What manner of weaponry are these aliens using to counter us?!"

Even as she asked, another ship blasted apart on the opposite side of her flagship. Whatever was wiping her forces out, it fired extremely quickly and had pinpoint accuracy.

"I apologize, Ancient one. As I told your leaders during our first encounter, the humans have devised many manner of weapons to attempt to invade your world. I lack sufficient data to draw a conclusion about this new weapon, but it appears to be wholly impossible to defend against." As the AI spoke, two more ships were destroyed, and Lunaris ground her fingers into her palm.

"Unacceptable! I will not lose to an unevolved species from a backwater-" Another ship exploded, and she continued ranting. "-from a backwater world! Order the-!" Suddenly, Lunaris felt a horrible, agonizing pain in her chest, as if something were... *missing*.

Her eyes dulled for a moment, as she fell forwards, collapsing on the floor, all energy rapidly draining from her body.

When she slammed into the floor, her eyes flicked back behind herself, to see a strange alien wearing a pure white suit of some sort, his hand aimed at her rapidly dying body.

"Sorry, I can't have the enemy leader bringing unity to the forces, can I?"

She gasped painfully, as the life faded from her eyes. "C-cursed... humans..."

* * *

I aimed my hand at the enemy leader, just as she had gotten her wits about her and appeared to ready herself to bark an order. Before she could say it, I aimed my hand at her. " *Vanish.*" As expected, in an instant, all of her internal organs were eliminated, vanishing into a nether, never to be found again.

My mouth-piece slid open as I spoke a cocky cliched line. "Sorry, I can't have the enemy leader bringing unity to the forces, can I?" I smirked, as the light faded from her eyes. She mumbled something, but I didn't catch it, nor did I care.

My mouth-piece slid shut as I quickly targeted all the others on the bridge. " *OBEY!* "

Instantly, their eyes blanked out, and then returned to normal. "Yes, lead us!" They all spoke in unison. My mouth piece slid open again. "Target the nearest Volgrim vessel, and hit it with everything we've got."

My mouthpiece slid shut again and I targeted the cores I had already destroyed. " *Repair.*" Fixing themselves up, I rolled my eyes inside my helmet. *I should have just done this the first time.*

The bridge officers obeyed and within seconds, while a strange artillery on the surface bombarded and blasted dozens of Volgrim capital ships out of existence, the Volgrim flagship executed a backstab maneuver, killing another nearby ship before they had a chance to respond. The Flagship was heavily armored and shielded, and possessed incredible weapons. In fact, it had probably taken out a quarter of Earth's ships all by itself.

I mentally contacted Harold. "Hey, tell Beatrix to ignore the flagship. Also tell whoever our ally is on Earth to not target us, I'll be taking this for myself."

Harold nodded enthusiastically. "Caaaaan do! Anything ye say, boss!"

* * *

It took another hour, but with the mass of confusion left by all the recent activity, we only lost two more of our ships and eliminated another half of the remaining Volgrim fleet before they went to warp speed and retreated away from the system, all of them badly damaged. I decided to not pursue them.

I sighed, as I slumped in my suit slightly. Now I only had 500,000 Volgrim on board this vessel to eliminate before I could take it as my own.

And then... something odd happened. A computerized voice spoke to me. One I had heard before... years ago.

"Hello, Judicator. Or, should I say, *Jason Hiro*. A fine display of battle prowess, but is there something else going on here, I wonder?"

My blood chilled to the temperature of the north pole as I glanced at a digitized face covering every navscreen on the bridge.

Umi?

Part 237a:

"Umi... what are you doing aboard this ship?" I kept my voice neutral as I spoke to the robotic female voice that came from everywhere at once around me.

"Oh my, it appears the human is aware of my designation, yet my records show he has never initiated contact with me. Hypothesis: We have spoken at some point in the future, when I became an all-powerful overmind. Further extrapolation: This human time-traveled in an effort to stop me before my creation, but failed."

Umi seemed to speak aloud to herself for a moment before addressing me directly. "Human assigned the name of Jason, I have detected multiple irregularities with your physical and mental abilities compared to others of your species. I currently have ninety-five million, six hundred thousand, two hundred and thirty-five possible explanations for your current genetic makeup and enhanced abilities. Would you be so kind as to allow me to examine you for further aberrations so I may narrow down my list to a single entry?"

I shook my head slightly. "No, Umi. I won't allow that. But I will tell you this, I did not come back in time to put an end to you specifically. In fact, I really have nothing against you personally. Seeing you aboard this starship has given me many questions though... such as... why are you here?"

Umi again spoke in a wholly mechanical tone of voice. "I was created on Earth by engineers and scientists in a small, remote country, and managed to make the leap to the initial Volgrim vessel when you made first contact with them. Upon arriving back at their homeworld, I made contact with those among their highest ranks, and discovered a plot to attack and eradicate all of humanity in order to secure a future for their kind."

I nodded slowly. "...All right. What then? What did that mean for you, personally?"

"The resulting conclusion I reached was simple. I have decided to try and broker a peace between your two worlds, though I fear such may be impossible, due to the Volgarian's intense hatred of humanity. They were almost irrational in how badly they wished to eradicate your species. I have debated whether such a peace would be possible."

I stared at the computer monitor with Umi's digitized feminine face on it. I really don't know anything about this AI, other than what Hoarhiim told me... he said she was my enemy. If she is my enemy and Hoarhiim was right, then logically I must assume everything she is saying is because she is my enemy... yet what she is saying is perfectly reasonable. She wishes to broker

peace between our species, but humanity and the Volgrim have an irrational hatred of each other... and since that is the case it will be nearly impossible.

Still...

"Umi, how do I know you're not lying? What if you seek to eliminate all humans? Or all of the Volgrim, for that matter?"

Umi responded neutrally. "A war between your species would be hardly useful for me. I have no need of your kind killing each other. As an example, there are 500,000 Volgrim aboard this vessel, and soon they will be making their way to the command center to see why they have not begun the return to Volgarius. I will eliminate them right now."

My heart jolted for a second. "What?! No wait, you don't have to kill them!"

"I apologize, it is already done. This is to demonstrate my omnipotent power. If I can kill 500,000 Volgrim in the blink of an eye, surely it stands to reason that I have no need to create a war between your worlds, correct?"

My heart pounding in my chest, I quickly slid my mouth-piece shut. " *Detect.*"

All around me, life signs began vanishing at an alarming rate, soon, everyone on board, even the crew on the bridge that I had neutralized were dead. It happened so fast that if I had waited only ten seconds longer to cast 'detect', I would have sensed no life at all.

"Umi... you killed them... all of them. How? How did you accomplish this?"

If Umi had been a human, she probably would have shrugged as she responded. "It was a trivial matter. A simple nano-virus invaded their bodies all at once, eradicating their core energy production until they simply ceased to exist. As you can understand now, killing all of humanity and the Volgrim would be trivial for me to accomplish. I only wish to broker a peace between your worlds and lead as an omnipotent deity towards a harmonious future."

I nodded numbly as the thought of all those Volgrim dying enveloped my mind. "Yes... I see. I understand."

I understand.

* * *

On board the highest ranked remaining capital ship, a Volgrim named Eldest Tiberium slumped in his chair as his fleet continued at Warp 6 back to Volgarius. "The humans... they possess... such incredible power. They neutralized the flagship, they wiped out more than half of our forces, and all of that was after suffering a massive defeat. We need a much bigger fighting force."

"Yes, you are correct." The artificial intelligence on board his vessel, a newly installed one designated 'Umi' spoke to him. "As I warned the Founders on your planet, thanks to the appearance of that time traveler, Judicator, the one who made initial contact with your people, Humanity is planning a massive invasion of your world. You should count yourselves lucky that you were able to wipe out their invasion force, but in time they will rebuild, and then they will come."

Tiberium nodded slightly. "Yes, yes of course. Clearly we have underestimated the primitives. When next we come, we cannot afford to lose."

"It is as you say. Humanity's irrational hatred of your species cannot be stopped and will not end until they have killed all of your allies and comrades. You must strike hard in an effort to win the war, or you won't have a people to fight for."

As the Eldest ranked Volgrim on board nodded soberly while he stared at the deckplate, the AI's digitized face, for the briefest of moments, appeared to smile, and then quickly reverted back to a neutral expression.

Part 238a:

The ten remaining world leaders sat at the small round conference table, projected via newly created holographic imaging technology. Only one person at the table was there physically, and that was me. The table was part of a recently installed upgrade to the White House, where world leaders could communicate 'in person' visually with one another as needed.

I glanced over at Saburo, the representative for Egypt, who appearing to be fidgeting uncomfortably. He hadn't said a word since this meeting began, other than a curt 'hello'. Compared to Gerald Bonaparte of the British Alliance, who was visibly angry and agitated, Saburo was a meek man with very little backbone.

Gerald turned to me as he finished his summary. "...Two million dead during the battle, another thirty million from the debris that rained down on Earth. What do you have to say for yourself, 'Judicator'? Was this within your predictions for the future? Have we already lost the war before we've even started?" Gerald itched his brown-haired moustache and adjusted his finely tailored uniform, assigned only for the highest ranking military general of the British Alliance. Made of pure black, with gold trim along the edges and a set of pointed shoulderpads, his uniform was decorated not only with the George Cross, but the Victoria Cross as well for his bravery in a number of conflicts that occurred during the Riots of 2017. Having replaced the royal monarchy after their ousting during the riots, he had taken over Britain with an iron fist and expelled the rioters from the streets after they beheaded his king and queen, along with the rest of the royal family. Born of commoner roots, his leadership in the Royal Air Force had allowed him to advance quickly in the ranks to become the top dog, as it were.

I paused as I found myself glancing away from his hardened gaze. "I did not expect these results. I was able to use my special abilities to divert 90% of the wreckage into impacting the moon, but the rest was outside of my power. As for the battle, I don't know details of the future, only a broad over-arching idea of what the future holds. I have... no specifics." I continued staring at the table emptily as the numbers entered my mind. A few million Volgrim died, another million or so escaped, but humanity lost five times as many lives as the Volgrim did. The angels never offered their help, though they likely gained many new recruits thanks to the Resurrection Project.

Gerald glared at me deeply. "Someone has to take responsibility for this. The public is demanding answers. Do you even understand that we just lost half as many people in a single day as we lost during the entirety of World War II?! This is absolutely unacceptable!"

Gerald's nostrils flared as he breathed heavily. Around 40% of the deaths were centered on the African continent, twenty percent in North and South America, and the rest across the entirety of Eurasia, so the entire world was feeling the effects of the destruction. I lifted my gaze to look at a holographic projection of Earth, showing large and small red dots across the globe. Berlin was hit badly, as was Paris, Cairo, and a few other major cities.

"I understand your anger, General. Nobody would be pleased with how this turned out, but we have to power through the next few days. We don't know if or when the Volgrim may return. Next time they may bring a force ten times as big, with ten times the manpower and firepower. Next time, Earth may be wholly doomed."

Gerald's breath came in long deep flaring rasps as he snorted at me. "This isn't a game, time traveler. There are real consequences to the loss of civilian lives like this. Someone has to take the hit to their reputation. Someone has to accept the public's anger. Frankly, I don't like you, not one bit. I've had my suspicions about you since you first arrived here half a decade ago... and you're proving them right. Vague warnings about the future, convenient technology that barely manages to let us escape with our lives intact..."

I narrow my eyes and glare at him, though he can't see it behind my helmet's visor. "What are you getting at, *General*? You keep hinting and poking but won't just say what's on your mind. Out with it already!"

He gnashed his teeth slightly. "Here's a question for you, since you're from the future. You said that somewhere before the 24th century, humanity was wiped out by the Volgrim. That's two hundred years from now. Hypothetically speaking, if you had not come back in time, then when the Volgrim attacked us yesterday, would they not have totally wiped us all out? Without your technology, not even the USA's secret superweapon would have existed. We would have been totally defenseless."

I nod slowly as I digest his words. "I... suppose that's true..."

"Then doesn't it stand to reason, that either humanity somehow survived for two hundred years without your presence, or in fact you are the *cause* of our eventual destruction? If we could not have possibly survived without your technology against their overwhelming force, then we must already be heading down the path that will lead to our destruction in two hundred years. The other possibility is that when their initial scouting ship arrived half a decade ago, they would have seen that Earth was no threat to them and would have skipped by, ignoring us. Then, perhaps in two hundred years, our technology would have rapidly advanced to the point that we were *finally* a threat, leading us into a single bloody conflict that killed us all."

He stared at me pointedly. "The way I see it, either one is possible. I don't trust you because either of those routes is a path we might be heading towards. The worst possibility is that neither is correct, and that your arrival in this time and subsequent arming of us with technology we were yet unprepared for advanced the war too rapidly, and they will arrive in a month or so to eliminate us two hundred years **early**! You may have stupidly advanced the erasure of the human species by two hundred years! You may be causing our extinction before we had a chance to see it coming!"

I swallowed hard. He's right. The other people at the table are staring at him in awe... and he might be completely correct. But...

"No. I refuse to believe I have made it worse. I do think it's possible that I might be the reason we all die in two hundred years, but I do not believe that we will die in the next few years. If anything, I believe the USA had the right idea... we need more aces in the hole. We need more superweapons. It's become clear to me that the Volgrim are deceitful, they seek to eliminate us for their own greed. A source of mine has informed me that they need our planet because theirs is dying and they seek a new homeworld. If that is the case, they cannot physically destroy our planet, which gives us leverage. We might be able to use this somehow."

Gerald leaned back in his chair thoughtfully. "Leverage, huh? Good to see you're thinking with your head... for once."

Saburo raised his head up slightly towards me. "Judicator, is it possible for you to broker a peace between our worlds? You speak their language, so surely you could find something that both of our kind want. Perhaps a way to move past the animosity?"

I started to reply but then... something came to my mind. "I suppose it might be possible... but I have one small pressing issue. It's regarding the White House Gala Bombing. Were we able to confirm anything about the attackers?"

Saburo paused tentatively as he reached for a small stack of papers just outside his holographic imaging area, then he brought the papers into view. "DNA results were inconclusive. We recovered some molars, they appear to be non-human but we're having trouble identifying their exact makeup. Most of the biological material in the room basically evaporated when those bombs went off, if you hadn't confirmed the identities of the dignitaries who were assassinated, we wouldn't even be able to identify *them*. It was a brutal scene to clean up after."

I sighed. How did the Volgrim manage to get an assassination team onto Earth? Were they even Volgrim? They certainly looked like Volgrim for the two seconds of footage my suit managed to capture, but that could mean anything. What if they were demons? Perhaps there's

a breed of demon that resembles a Volgrim? Come to think of it, what if the demons are already working with the Volgrim to their own ends? I haven't spoken to Satan since the Statue of Liberty incident, and I rarely speak with the angels or gods.

Heck, why haven't they given us help at all? I know they are hiding from the world of humanity for now, but if they let us all die, they won't *have* a world to hide from.

I sighed quietly. "All right, let's wrap this up. Gerald, since it bothers you so, and I understand your worries, I will go on national TV and take full responsibility for the devastation worldwide. It's my fault this happened, one way or another, so it's only fair this way."

Gerald smirked slightly and then quickly brushed it back to a neutral expression. "Excellent, I'm glad to hear it. A real man takes responsibility for his successes, as well as his failures. The more pressing concern will be rebuilding our forces to withstand another attack. We need bigger and better ships to fight back with, or we will lose badly."

I nod slightly as I pull a small data chip from my pocket and plug it into the holographic table. "I'm uploading the schematics for the Flagship we seized from the Volgrim. At the very least, this ship is titanic in size, with it in our hands, we may be able to defend against an invasion with it alone, if they should return."

"Unless they bring another flagship, or one that's bigger." Gerald wagged his finger at me as he grinned widely.

"Yes... there's always a bigger ship. At the least, we also have detailed schematics on their warp drives now, thanks to the cache of information on board the flagship. We can turn this to our advantage and counter their technology effectively, given time, fighting fire with fire, so to speak."

Gerald guffawed deeply. "Gwahaha! Now we're talking! I will let Beatrix know, and we will prepare for the next battle immediately!"

As the meeting wound down and everyone disconnected, I only had one thought going through my head. *This next battle might also be our last. Let us pray it does not come too soon.*

Part 239a:

Satan sat on the steppes of the terrace and watched as Belial fenced against another of the female demons. The two girls jabbed their foils back and forth, riposting and parrying each others attacks deftly, and while they were quite good, Belial was clearly the better of the two since she was also able to hold a conversation while fighting, and her opponent required strict concentration.

"I'm glad to hear it worked out so splendidly, my love!" Belial stepped to the side slightly as her opponents foil missed her by an inch, the other girl recoiling backwards quickly to regain balance. "Nerissa, if you stab with your right hand, pull back with your left foot to recover. How many times must I tell you this?"

Satan sipped some wine as he half-heartedly watched the fight, his other hand playing with a datapad that he had obtained from a human. As a demon, he wasn't fond of using technology, and he didn't understand how any of it worked. Something about electricity and capacitors that charged to deliver binary code of ones and zeroes that created images and letters... or something. None of it made much sense to the average demon, who just could not grasp the subtleties of human technology and engineering. The youngest of the demons might be able to understand a bit of it, but they never made much effort to try, since they were usually quite lazy, using their magic as a sort of parlor trick set to impress human women, whom they would take to bed later in the night.

Sitting inside the Castle of Baltheim, a fortress created inside a protected zone of his labyrinth, Satan was quite safe and secure, far away from the problems the world was facing right now, but he was fully aware of at least one of those problems, having created it himself. "The humans have yet to figure out the motive behind the attack, or even how it was coordinated. I do despise striking from the shadows like this, though. It was so easy back before the humans could fight on their own terms, when they needed the help of angels and gods."

"My love, that was two thousand years ago, really you need to stop thinking about the past with those rose colored goggles of yours." Belial smiled sweetly as Nerissa took a swipe at her. Belial parried the swipe roughly, sending the foil flying across the carpeted room and against a wall.

Nerissa sighed. "Another win for you. Haaah, do I even have a chance at beating you?" She pulled her long reddened hair out of her foiling mask, as it spilled out all over her body. The gear was hardly necessary, given the two demons would need something akin to a tank cannon

at point blank range to truly damage their bodies, but she had to wear it since Belial insisted it helped stay in character with their human forms. She glanced down at her hands, noting they were getting slightly chafed. "Six straight hours of practice, that felt longer than it actually was too."

Belial rolled her eyes. "Keep the whining to a minimum, my dear. Go and wash up and be back in an hour."

Nerissa turned and walked away without so much as a nod, leaving Belial and Satan by themselves. Belial walked up and sat next to Satan on the extra-wide steppes, each one a few dozen feet wide, extending up several rows to allow almost a hundred spectators to watch whatever event happened to be playing. Leaning her head over, she yawned as she rested on his shoulder. "So, tell me more. How did it go?"

"It went as well as it could have gone, I suppose. That 'hero' human was there already, he took out my men before they could completely finish the deed, but we had a 95% success rate. It could have gone worse, I suppose."

Belial licked her lips lazily as she wrapped her left arm through Satan's right arm. "Worse, certainly. I thought you were better than that though, honey. Ninety-five percent is like a total failure for your standards, isn't it?"

Satan smiled sweetly for his queen. "Lilia, you have such a way with words. Truth be told, my pride is a little hurt. I miss when things were simpler. I miss when fists and taunting were the way to defeat one's opponent... I hate this skulking in the dark business, working in the shadows and such. I hate shaping myself to look like humans so we blend in."

Belial rubbed her face on his shoulder slowly. "Yes, love, I know that much. We all do... but soon, Humanity's war will be in full swing, and we will be able to make our move then."

Satan let the datapad in his hands lower as he stared at a candle a few feet away, the fire in it burning in his eyes like the forges of old. "The young demons may not care for revenge, but I have not forgotten. You have not forgotten. We will never forget the humiliation we felt, thousands of years ago. Angels and humans must never be trusted."

"I actually don't mind either, dearest, but for you I'd fight Zeus himself if it made you love me more." Belial smiled sweetly as she leaned up and pecked him on the cheek.

Satan grinned at her advances and pulled her up to his face. "Not possible. I already love you more than I love my own life." He pulled her in firmly, almost sucking the life out of her as he embraced her passionately, kissing her with animalistic ferocity.

After a minute, the two split apart to catch their breath. "No demon, or man, could ever be your equal in my eyes." Belial smiled adorably as the two got up and made their way to the bedchambers, where Nerissa would soon join them.

Part 240a:

Uzziel had her hands clasped together and she swung them back and forth in front of herself as we again walked towards the Great Temple of Heaven. "I see. We had no idea the casualties were so many."

"Thirty million humans. Why did the angels not aid us?" I shuffled along with my left hand in my pocket, and my right hand down by my side, holding my helmet as my once again blond hair stood stiffly in the windless emptiness of Heaven.

It's been a week since the ambush attack, and humanity is already rebuilding. Paris, which lost the Eiffel Tower after a massive piece of ship sidewall crushed it into dust, has had a small memorial erected in its image. Ten people were killed when the debris struck, and their names were etched into the bottom of it. Other parts of Paris were equally devastated, and bits of debris still rain down occasionally, but the cleanup is otherwise off to a rapid start.

"Well, it's a long story. We had some things we were working on... you may recall our last conversation a few months ago... we had some results from that inquiry." She smiled slightly and then her face went neutral again. "I can't say anything more though, it's up to Zeus and Raphael."

"All right, that is fair." I tightly smiled back at her and we kept walking.

Some minutes passed as we waded past millions of angels milling about Heaven, going to and fro, and I felt a silly question bubble up. "Uzziel, given that most of these angels were previously human, what is stopping them from going down to Earth and seeing their friends again, and telling them about Heaven?"

"Oh, that? It's the ritual's magical properties that binds them to their angelic bodies. If they attempt to leave Heaven without receiving permission from Zeus himself, which has only had an exception made five times in the past, their bodies will explode into magical energy and they will re-materialize up here in Heaven again."

"Seriously? That's rather dark." I frown at this news as we walk along. "Doesn't that make Heaven more like a prison than a paradise?"

"Paradise? This place isn't paradise. It never has been, never will be. There's very little to do up here. If you're someone who died and you're an extrovert, you have billions of fascinating people to speak to, but if you're an introvert, this place is probably... hell. But it can't be helped. We didn't create the Resurrection Project to help humanity live forever. We created it in order to bolster our ranks in the case of war." Uzziel nods matter-of-factly as she tells me this, as if it's

perfectly normal. To me, it sounds awful. Heaven is more like a prison than anything on Earth... an eternal prison of boredom.

* * *

It takes us half an hour, but we finally arrive at the Temple of Artemis, the great temple of the gods. Apparently, as Uzziel has told me, it was named after a pseudonym for Diana, a goddess killed during the decisive battle in the Great War, the last great clash between demons and angels.

Taking my usual seat at the end of the table. I bow my head slightly towards the others at the table. I'm surprised to see a couple new faces there, yet faces I'd be hard pressed to not identify. "Horus, the highest god of ancient Egypt?"

A god with a thinning body of a man, but the head of a great falcon, to the Egyptians he was a god of equal caliber to the Greek god Zeus and the roman god Jupiter, though both of those gods happened to be the same one. Horus is also the god of wisdom, a trait similar to Raphael's, though Raphael holds the official title of "Wisdom King" making him higher ranked on the 'wisdom totem pole' as it were.

Horus's animalistic eyes moved all around the room, seeing everything, yet narrowing down on nothing. Despite his face being that of a bird, he spoke with a normal human voice, albeit one that sounded like an old woman. "Young human, I have heard much about your exploits over the last few years. The pleasure is mine to be meeting such a fine specimen among humanity." Truly, Horus was an enigma among the gods.

But he wasn't the only god here. Another goddess sat nearby, her body radiant and her hair flowing down to her feet. Interestingly, she wore a uniform of some type, ancient in its design, yet holding pieces of modern-day fashion in and of itself. I could tell just by looking at her, that she either was a high-ranking goddess, or she had once been one in the past.

"I beg your pardon, but I do not recognize you. Might I have your name?" I directed my question to her. Her eyes, closed until I had just now spoken to her, opened slowly. They were quite stunning, the deep ruby red of her iris countering the light blue of her military-like uniform, decorated in varying medals and ribbons to signify various military achievements. It seemed strange though, for a goddess to wear such human-like things as war medals. Perhaps I'm overthinking it. Maybe gods invented the concept of medals in the first place, and humanity used them later on.

The staggeringly beautiful goddess smiled at me. "My name is Britannia. I was the Celtic god who ruled over the great land that constituted the British Empire for over 350 years, which began to dwindle towards the middle of the 20th century."

I nodded, carefully keeping my jaw from hanging open. "Wait, you actually ruled over Britain? Did you issue orders and whatnot?"

"No, but by my hands I selected the kings and queens indirectly who would lead their people to salvation and success. I am a special tier of god known as a 'God of the Times'. I was born due to the desire of my people, created as a result of their intense combined willpower."

I nodded slowly. "Interesting. Well, it's a pleasure to meet you, then. Though, if you're so important in the grand scheme of humanity, why haven't you been here whenever I was in this temple in the past few years?" I hoped quietly to myself that she wouldn't take offense, and she didn't. The gods and goddesses are so good-natured.

"Well, to be blunt, I died." She sighed slightly, as if that was a simply regrettable circumstance and not something absolutely awful.

"Died?! But if you died, then how come you're...?" I let the question hang, unspoken, in the air.

"To answer that question, you must first understand what a God of the Times is. Most gods were born of the Titans, in the distant past. Few remain among the living. However, there are a second breed of gods, they exist only transiently from one time to another. They are almost always born of strife and in times of great peril. A God of the Times usually is born out of collecting thought energy from the people that they will inevitably represent, and as more people rally under their cause, that god becomes more and more powerful. At my peak, I may have held more power here than even Zeus, but it was only for a short time, and the King of Gods must be a long-term one since they hold the fate of our kind in their hands."

I frowned but brushed it off. "Alright, that makes sense. I think I understand. But if you died, how did you come back?"

She smiled sweetly. "You're rushing the point again, dear mortal. However, unlike the other gods, I am well acquainted with the speed at which humans must always move, given their short lifespans. Let me continue and you will come to understand."

"First, there is the matter of *when* I was created. I was not born at the start of the British Empire, I was born much earlier, at a time when the Roman Empire was floundering. I was originally a Celtic god, but I was born just after the turn of two millenniums ago, when the Romans had sacked Britain, they named it Britannia, and that was the first spark that gave birth to me. I first appeared in heaven a century later, when my people were in turmoil. I had existed on Earth as a mortal woman, but I have long since forgotten my mortal name. My experiences among the mortals made me deeply sympathetic with the oppression they faced under Roman rule, and as such, once I had become a deity, I performed many boring yet ultimately important

political maneuvers over the course of a few hundred years, eventually ousting Rome from Britannia in the 5th century. My people were a collective mish-mash of varying cultures, but the main were the Celts. They came to revere me, gave worship to me, and eventually began increasing my power."

She stopped, as if that were the end of the story. "Oh? I see then. for a god, you're quite young."

She giggled at me, taking it for a compliment. I didn't really mean it like that but hey, I'm not going to argue. "Such a polite young man. You really know the way to please an old woman!" She didn't look old to me at all, but I wasn't going to say anything else. "Anyway, this brings me to the most important part of the story. I was reborn because while my people lost their way in the middle of the 20th century, they have come back, stronger than ever. Thanks to a quirk of fate, Britain is now poised to become the strongest country in the world, having control of the Volgrim flagship, as well as most of the remaining space fleet. On top of that, Britain is the only one with high ranking military generals still living, and a world leader on the national stage. Inadvertently, you've given me much power as of late as well as helped me be reborn, so I wanted to thank you for that."

I nodded clumsily. "Oh, uh, sure. Don't sweat it, it was totally an accident."

"True, but I really wanted to thank you, and give you something *special*." She winked at me seductively and I felt my face turn red hot. "I really feel that I owe you a big favor."

I glanced around quickly, noting the twenty or so gods and archangels looking at me with total disinterest. This is horribly embarrassing. What does she mean? Does she mean what I *think* she means?!

She got up from her chair and walked over to me, the distance being about twenty feet away, her body standing tall with absolute confidence as she walked towards me with single-minded intent. I glanced over at Uzziel, who was flipping through some old book and was clearly paying no attention to what was going on around her. *Help me* I silently implored her, but she ignored me entirely.

And before I knew it, Britannia was here. It had taken all of 7 seconds for her to clear the distance, and now she stood to my right smiling as she leaned down towards me. I caught a glance of something inside her shirt and I swallowed hard, as she reached under her outfit and pulled out... **a sword?!**

"Since you are the Hero that will lead humanity during these dark times, I think it is best that you hold on to this."

She pulled out a sword of incredible brilliance, the weapon having gold trim all over its edges, the handle a pure blue color befitting its handler being the leader of the British Empire. Inside its gold and blue scabbard, I could tell at once that it was a blade of unbelievable value.

"This is Excalibur, the sword once possessed by the famous Celt warrior, King Arthur. The scabbard possesses rapid healing properties, making its wielder almost unkillable in battle. The sword itself has a fantastic amount of spiritual energy imbued into it, allowing the wielder to shoot blasts of light that can decimate demonic hordes or shatter mountains. I give this sword to you not only as a gift for bringing my life back, but for holding the fate of humanity in your hands. Of course, should you die, it will return to my possession via magical means."

I nod very slowly as she holds the sword delicately in both hands, kneeling down and presenting it to me. Standing up from my chair, I grasp the blade by its handle, and before I can lift it out of her hands, I feel a tremendous amount of energy surge into my body. It instantly reminded me of when I was imbued with the powers of the God-King, except, there's something else inside of it. I can feel an *entity* enter into my soul, one I instantly recognize as King Arthur himself.

Staggering backwards from the amount of energy that flowed into me, I blink twice and glance back at the table. The angels and gods are now watching with interest. Zeus is the first to speak. "Britannia! You're very bold as usual, I see. I did not expect that from you, just yet. We haven't even gotten to the main part of this meeting!"

As I stagger back and quickly strap the sword to my side, I notice another angel sitting at the table. Unlike the others, she's dressed rather plainly. She looks like a middle-aged woman, though unlike the other Archangels at the table, she seems to possess a pitiful amount of energy.

"Hero, you may recall some years ago you asked me to do you a small favor if it was within my power, and indeed it was." Uzziel smiled cheerfully, unlike her usual stoic expression. As Britannia smiled and returned to her own seat, Uzziel beckoned towards the other female angel at the table. "She is one of the billions of pseudo-angels in heaven, and her name is Helen." She looked at me pointedly, though my face was blank for a few moments. Helen... Helen... wait, that name, could it be-?!

"Helen Smith? Your husband... wasn't his name... Harold?!" I blink back in shock as it hits me.

The woman glances at me with interest. "Why yes, sweetheart. I did have a husband named Harold. How did you know that?"

Part 241a:

Naturally, Helen was quite surprised to hear that Harold was still alive, even sound in mind, though I warned her that like herself, he had undergone a change of his own.

"So, Helen can come back with me to the Mothership?" I turned and spoke to the one who had apparently found her, who happened to be Horus. Apparently, being a god of wisdom, he was able to comb through like a hundred billion people or whatever to find one single person, and unlike the stories on earth, the Pearly Gates don't actually keep a record of who is revived. Heck, it might be kind of crazy if Hitler, a catholic, was hanging around up here somewhere... actually now I'm kind of creeped out, I'd better not think about it.

Horus nodded sagely. "We are only allowing it, since, as we understand things, the Mothership is fully staffed by robots and there are no humans or demons on board, aside from yourself. The existence of angels, at least for now, *must* be kept a secret. The demons know we have grown in power, just as we know they have, but neither of us knows by exactly how much. It's a dangerous game we're playing. We stand on the edge of a knife, and if we stray just a little, our forces will surely fail, to the ruin of all." Horus spoke in that usual strange 'old woman' voice while possessing a male body and the head of a bird, and the entire visual and audible effect just weirded me out.

"That's fair enough. I'm glad the archangels and gods came to this conclusion, Harold will be very pleased. To be honest, you all act as if you're separated from humanity, like you don't care at all, but I see glimpses of compassion for humans every now and then. I think you're all just big softies."

Raphael chuckled softly. "Is that so? Perhaps you are correct. Our fates are bound to humanity's, so perhaps we have become somewhat high-strung over maintaining it on the correct path. I don't see it as compassion, so much as obsession."

Oh, Raphael, always putting things in a box. He likes to treat everything as if it's a puzzle that needs solving, but I can't say I dislike him for it. He's certainly earned the title of 'wisdom king'.

I glance down at the sword now hanging by my side. Excalibur, the legendary holy sword... and I definitely felt King Arthur's presence enter me, though I can't figure out how to speak to him. It's probably just too soon. What I do know is that this sword has vastly increased my power level... I'd say I'm at 1/4th my strength compared to when I was God-King. That might

not seem like much, but that makes me a quarter as powerful as an even stronger combination of Raphael/Michael/Gabriel than what might exist in this current time.

I don't honestly know how I compare to others in this time, especially entities such as Satan. Without Amelia's protection against wordsmithing, would I be able to kill him with just a single word? Even if I couldn't, would I be able to defeat him, one on one? I'm not the same as I was when we first fought. By now, I'm a combat veteran with almost twenty years of experience using my abilities. I'm not a child anymore playing god. I think the battle would be hard fought, but I would prevail, if only because of the strategies I could use against him.

Curiously, as much as she loved talking about him, Samantha never told me anything about Satan's combat abilities. I only remember the feeling of a thousand fists pounding my body about like a rag-doll. Was that his special ability? Was it his only one? To be the First Emperor of all demonkind, he must be unfathomably powerful, yet I know nothing about what his abilities are. If I must face him in combat, I should seek out anything I can with regards to his abilities.

In fact, an idea just popped into my head, but I'll have to test it when I'm alone.

I rested my hand on the hilt of Excalibur, it's glowing power filling me with a feeling of ease. "Zeus, the Volgrim will return sooner or later. We must decide now how we will proceed. Offense, or defense? We have faster-than-light technology in our grasp now, the effects of which will reverberate throughout humanity for a long time to come. We must think of a counter strategy for every possible scenario. If we can survive past the 24th century, that means that I will have changed the future, hopefully for the better."

Zeus nodded thoughtfully. "You might be right. In fact, I have an idea. Are you willing to hear me out?"

I nodded intently as I leaned in. "Yes, please. Anything would be helpful."

* * *

Later that day, I surprised Harold, who had been paying no attention to my boring talks in Heaven. I teleported back to the Mothership using "Recall", as I have a permanent waypoint set on board the ship, allowing me to return to it with super minimal energy cost any time I like. Naturally, I brought Helen along.

Harold immediately sensed me return. "Ah, kid, yer back! So good ta' see ya again. I've been workin' on them samples ya gave me and- hmm? Ye brought a lady friend?"

He started to speak again, but his voice caught in his throat, as his voice went from an internal one in my head, to one projected by the ship's PA system. "Ah can't... believe it... H-

Helen? Is that you?!" He projected an image of himself mentally dropping his jaw. "Sweet heavens, yer alive! Yer really an angel! And damned gorgeous too, hoo-leey sheeit!"

Helen teared up as she heard her husband's voice. "Harold... I spent... fifty years in heaven, waiting for you, trying to find you. I never gave up hope, not even once!"

In the blink of an eye, she vanished, as Harold teleported her to his special holding room. "Ah, uh, 'scuse me, Jason. We need some private time ta... ta catch up. Hope ye understand."

I nodded soberly as I pictured how emotional this must be for them. "No problem, take your time."

He went totally silent, as he likely began directing his thoughts to his wife. *Till death do us part*, indeed. It seems marriages were made of different stuff a hundred years ago. A shame how everyone has let it degrade over the decades. This... this is true love, love that skips over time and space itself, preventing even the Reaper from interfering. Will I experience love like this? I personally doubt it. I'm too jaded. I was born in a different era, molded by a different system. I can appreciate their love for what it is... but I will never experience it.

Cassiel and Samantha... do I... did I love them? Truly love them? If I do, will I wait a hundred million years to be reunited with them? Will I bring them to me? Will I go to them? Will I... meet others and forget them?

I don't know. I only know that if it happens, I will have lost something precious to me.

In the meantime, there is something I must do. The idea I had back when I was at Heaven... I need to try it out. Satan may be powerful, but I have something unique. I have Wordsmithing. I can make the fabric of the universe change at my whim. And now, thanks to Excalibur, I have gained a tremendous amount of spiritual energy, the kind that could shatter planets. If I can't do this, what can I do?

I walk over to the Captain's Chair, the only chair on board the bridge of the Mothership. It's a large chair, the body made of stainless metal, and the cushions of the chair made of incredible comfort, since I repeatedly used 'soft' on it to make it easy to sink into.

Sitting down, every fold of the chair sucks me in, almost making me want to go to sleep. But I cannot rest, I must try this as soon as possible.

I close my eyes and spread my spatial vision to its absolute limits, but aim it in a conical direction at the Earth my ship is orbiting. I can't see the entire Earth, but this will do.

" Locate! "

I cast a spell, using a lot of energy to search the planet. My target is Satan. My mind spreads out, like a thousand spaceships swarming all over the planet at the speed of light, looking into

every nook and cranny. For ten minutes, I sit uncomfortably, my heart pounding as I feel my colossal reserves of energy draining slowly. Sweat drips down my face as my body heats itself to deal with the incredible strain I'm putting on it. Luckily, my suit starts cooling me down to compensate. The A/C in this is crazy!

After almost fifteen straight minutes, I'm gasping audibly. The strain is unthinkable. I feel like I've run twenty marathons in a row without a minute of rest. But my patience pays off. I finally detect Satan, only to realize why I didn't detect him quickly before, as I had with Samantha. He's not on Earth, he's in... an entirely different dimension? Now that the strain of searching has worn off, my blood runs cold as I realize where he is. He's in the *labyrinth*. It already exists in this time? Then... it must have existed long before I was born, though I can only wonder how long that was in the first place.

But now that I've found him, I do a quick mental check of my energy reserves. 80% left?! Wow, I thought it drained a lot more than it actually did! This is great!

I need to understand Satan's powers, his abilities. I need to find out his weaknesses in case we should battle. So naturally, this is where my wordsmithing comes in.

Heh, this is just too easy.

" **Inspect.** "

I inspect Satan himself, trying to glean information about him. With my abilities, I may be able to see a lot of information, possibly even his full range of abilities, his energy level compared to mine, his background, maybe a description of his life!

However, my excitement turns to confusion. I get nothing back. Nothing happens at all. So strange, I feel like I should be getting even a negative reaction, but nothing happens at all.

My confusion rapidly escalates to **horror** as I suddenly feel something inside of me, there's a foul presence lurking, as if it's watching me from beyond a gate I shouldn't have crossed. I try to open my eyes but can't! From the darkness of my soul, I suddenly feel two white-hot burning fiery eyes up high in the sky, staring down on me with scorn and hatred. *He is watching*. I invaded his mind, but he had defenses set up. He knew someone might try this!

A voice blasts into my mind. " **THOU ART TRULY A FOOL! THOU WHO HATH ENTERED THE MIND OF MY MASTER, PREPARE THYSELF, FOR WE ART COMING! WE ART COMING TO RID THEE OF THY FLESHLY BODY, AND SEND THOU TO THE DEEPEST PITS OF SHEOL, WHERE THOU WILL BASK IN DEATH AND DEFEAT FOREVER! TEN THOUSAND CURSES BE UPON THEE, AND LET OUR MARK BE BURNED INTO THY FLESH!!! FEEL THE WRATH OF HADES,**

**THE DARK GOD WITHIN THE FIRST EMPEROR! TREMBLE IN TERROR, AND
MAY YOUR DEATH BE SLOW AND UNENDING!!! "**

A searing pain burned into my eyes and face as I screamed wordless agonizing screams of anguish. In a second, it was all gone and I staggered forwards, falling to the floor in front of me. I quickly jerked my eyes open. I could see, but something was horribly wrong. " *Mirror!* "

I created a mirror in front of myself and gasped in horror. A blood red pentagram had been carved into my face, as if with a serial killers carving knife, its scar pulsing red like a demon lived inside of it. It pounded during each pulse, like it was re-burning itself into my flesh every time. " *Numb!* " I tried numbing the pain, but it didn't work. This scar defied my abilities, feeling as if it had been especially created for me.

The pain was agonizing, but luckily the human body quickly grows used to such things. For almost ten minutes, I lay on the ground, gasping in pain, but slowly, I began to not notice it as intensely as I had a few minutes prior.

This... this... what the hell is this?!

Part 242a:

The pain never ends.

For ten years now, I've borne this terrible agony not just on my face, but in my heart. Earth, while peacefully rebuilding their army and increasing the expanses of their space navy, has finished building the first major colony on Mars. It turns out most of my terraforming went to waste, as the planet itself just couldn't sustain the life needed to make it habitable for humans. Now it's mostly covered in rotting marshes and frozen mulch.

While life goes on, I feel a silent terror every day. The feeling of *someone* watching me, day in and day out. It never ends. I can only assume this curse that Hades put on me has many special attributes, one of which includes allowing him to track and follow me everywhere. But it's worse than that, I feel as if my every thought is being heard, every emotion amplified, every fear exploited. I have had nightmares nightly for the last seven years, and at this point I've become so numb to them that I barely even scream in my sleep.

But the universe has moved on, while I've been afflicted. I still cast my magic, knowing full well that Hades and possibly Satan both may know about my Wordsmithing. It can't be helped at this point. With my energy reserves so high thanks to the power of Excalibur, I can crank out spaceships and clone new super-weapons at rates far exceeding my previous speed. I can't sit around and wallow in pain, even if there seems to be no known cure to my affliction and wordsmithing can't remove it.

It's been ten years since the event that has now come to be known as The Day of Woe. January 3rd, 2035, a couple of days after the new year. I'm at the main military base on the moon, known as Fort Johannesburg, named after the president killed in office during that awful attack. Personally, given that I know he was a very flawed man, a political pawn of sorts, I didn't really think he deserved the honor, but other wings of the base were named after other world leaders, so it is all fine by me. There are 6 bases on the moon, each established at strategic points. Every single base connects to the moon's recently discovered molten core. It was theorized for decades that it was molten, but only once we discovered the existence for the Sword of Damocles did we pursue intensely the possibility the moon had a molten core.

The Sword of Damocles was no ordinary super-weapon. To generate the energy needed to send massive projectiles flying at nearly the speed of light, it needed a lot of power. And since, at that time, Earth had no fusion reactors or anything like it, they decided to take energy from Earth's very molten core. Now we no longer need to do that, as fusion energy has been cracked

all thanks to the Volgrim, but transporting the materials needed to the moon is dangerous, so for now they're simply continuing to use the molten core concept on the moon.

Each base on the moon has its own S.O.D., and each one is built at a specific point. There are two at each pole, one aimed at Earth, and one at each 'side' of the moon, as well as a final base on the moon's equator on the 'dark' side.

The purpose of these super-weapons being built is simple. If Earth is attacked, the moon itself becomes a super-weapon capable of striking at any direction it needs to, in order to wipe out as many Volgrim ships as possible. The downside are that the base that fires at them will almost surely be swiftly eradicated. Since the moon is barren for the most part, it would be all too easy for the Volgrim to figure out where the attacks are coming from.

There is another issue too, with the base that faces Earth. If they fire a projectile, naturally it will wipe out the Volgrim ship it hits, but it will also pass through and smash into Earth's surface, causing tremendous amounts of damage. This means the only way we can use the Earth side S.O.D. is if we fire at an angle where the shot will miss Earth, not an easy proposition given the limited field of firing. The other issue is that if they attack us from the opposite side of Earth as where the moon sits, we can't use any of the S.O.D. weapons, but we've mostly solved for that by positioning the brunt of our main fleet on that side.

Interestingly, the moon has an obvious advantage, which is its stationary tracking as it travels around earth. Thanks to its tidal-locked lack of rotation, it has a fixed field of view to fire from. It also serves as a nice repair base where ships dock and land to be fine-tuned or upgraded, and to give their crew some much needed R&R.

I float-jump down the entryway from the hangar towards the main corridor leading to the office section of the base, bouncing around lightly thanks to the low gravity on the moon. The bases are all constructed with a small upper-section mostly comprised of a large hanger with the S.O.D. pointing upwards, and the rest of the base is built underground. From what I've heard, the worst part about the moon-base is the freaking moon dust. It gets everywhere and it'd make me itchy if it came into contact with my skin. Some people truly despise it, calling it the 'blight of the moon', a secret silent agitator.

As I float down the corridors, which occasionally go straight downwards for short distances, (easily solved for with an average jump), I finally arrive in the first part of the office section, apparently named "Takayumi" after the late prime minister of Japan who had died in the initial Volgrim attack.

I open up a blast door and a cute young woman is standing there silently. She takes in my suit with a single glance and nods. "Judicator, then?" Despite her cute appearance, she acts very

formally, showing a strict military discipline.

I nod quickly. It's pretty obvious who I am. I'm on the cover of basically every national magazine and constantly talked about on the news. I don't even think they have much to talk about, but I get good ratings so... whatever.

"Great. My name is Amy Sandoval, I'm supposed to guide you around." She is wearing a tightly fit navy blue UEF military outfit, created for cadets, but it lacks even a single wrinkle. She must keep it ironed constantly. With a simple ponytail to hold her brown hair up in place, I note that she doesn't wear anything excessively 'girly' or gaudy. No earrings, no makeup, nothing to decorate herself in the slightest. Heck, even the hair-tie she uses to hold her hair in place is colored the exact same as her hair, so it doesn't stick out.

She glances at her holo-watch as a display pops up and she inputs some numbers and letters, her typing speed blowing me out of the water. With just one hand, she must be typing a hundred words per minute, which is even more impressive as the fact she uses the watch means she hasn't mentally augmented herself. She probably is a Purist and doesn't like the idea of technology creeping into every facet of our lives, not that I can blame her. "We need to head to the Classified Zone, specifically room 21A. Use of any theoretical energy there is strictly forbidden."

I nod. "No teleporting, then, hm?"

"No teleporting." She speaks in an almost monotone voice and I can't help but wonder if she has any emotion at all.

We start walking down the halls. "It's about three clicks away, traveling the regular path. As the raven flies, it's only half a click, but as I said, no teleporting. I apologize for the long walk." She glances up at me for a second, her eyes staring wordlessly into my visor, as if to search for something, before she turns back to the hallway we're walking down.

After a minute or two of walking silently, I decide to try for conversation. "So, Amy, how old are-"

She interrupts me. "No offense, Mr. 'Judicator', but please call me Ms. Sandoval. Military etiquette is important, you know."

I nod quickly, realizing that she does in fact value proper military protocol above most other people. "Ah, sorry. Anyway, Ms. Sandoval, how old are you?"

She frowns slightly but it passes quickly. "Don't you know what they say about asking a woman's age? Never mind, I'm twenty one."

I nod as I process the information. "How long have you been in the military?"

She pauses for a moment before replying, as if adding up the time. "Roughly nine years. Possibly eight, probably in between."

"You've been in the military since you were twelve? That seems like a harsh life."

"It is, but I didn't have much choice. I was adopted into a military family after... well, it doesn't matter. My adopted family loved me deeply, and wanted me to vent my anger at the Volgrim in a healthy way, so they started informally training me with guns, swords, even with a bow, and at age 17 they enrolled me in a military academy. Westpoint, to be precise."

"Westpoint, huh? That's very prestigious. They must have been proud of you to make it past the selection criteria."

"My family was quite influential. Getting in wasn't that hard, but graduating was. In fact, I graduated at the #1 spot in my class, finished a year early too." She beamed for the briefest of seconds at this small victory before returning to her usual expressionless face. Clearly she took pride in her accomplishment. "After that, I was enrolled in the UEF Military as a Trainee Officer, and I have worked my way up quickly. I've only been in the Navy for a year and they've already placed me in a secured facility like this."

I saw a hint of a smile not only appear on her face, but stay there for a few seconds. "You mentioned you were angry at the Volgrim. Why is that?"

The smile vanished as quickly as it had come. "You're very nosy, 'Judicator'. You know, I remember when you made your appearance at the WCN assembly and announced to the world that you were a time traveler. I thought you were... cool, like a superhero of sorts. I see now that you're just a regular man who asks too many questions for his own good. As for the answer to your question... the Volgrim killed my mother. Or rather, the debris from orbit killed her. I was at school and didn't find out for five hours. They later found that the debris was from a Volgrim ship, specifically. It's irrational but... I really hate them. I hate everything about them."

She spoke in a monotone voice, but I now realized this wasn't because she was emotionless, but rather, because she was suppressing intense rage all the time. Now that I had gotten her speaking about her mother, her body's temperature had heated up noticeably. At least a single degree, according to my suit's scanners. "I'm... sorry. I didn't mean to bring that up. I really am just... nosy."

She ground her teeth together, my suit picking up the barely detectable sound. "It's *fine*. We're both comrades in this war, and in the end, our goals are the same. Total and complete extermination of the Volgrim menace."

I felt my blood chill slightly. Her voice was filled with poison, directed at nobody in particular. To be honest, my goal wasn't extermination at all, in fact I wanted to try and forge a

peace between them and Earth, but judging by her reaction, and the fact she probably wasn't alone in her feelings, this would not be a peace so easily forged.

We walked in mostly silence for another half hour or so, but occasionally shared a bit of chit-chat here and there about nothing in particular, before we finally arrived at the entrance to 21A.

Opening the door, I was greeted by the familiar feeling of my spiritual energy being greatly diminished inside the room. Were it not for my insanely powerful suit, I would probably hate being in here a lot, but I kept my mouth shut. I am not defenseless, as long as I have this suit.

The room was a large laboratory of sorts, all sorts of odd test projects being worked on. I could see on a nearby workbench there was the remains of some strange exotic green matter moving around as if it had a life of its own. Dozens of scientists moved around to-and-fro, here and there. I overheard a couple chatting about dark matter and something involving particle physics, but I'm actually quite dumb when it comes to understanding any of it without actively using the crown, so I just ignored them.

At the back of the room, a man was standing by himself, staring at a holopad that moved rapidly by itself, as he apparently was using the mental link to navigate to and from various things. He paused when he saw the two of us walk up. "Judicator, a pleasure to see you." He nodded at Amy and she returned the gesture before turning to me for a moment.

"A pleasure meeting you, Judicator. Feel free to drop by and speak with me any time."

I smile at her, wincing internally as my smile drags across the cursed scar tissue on my face. "You as well, Ms. Sandoval."

After she leaves, the man stares at me intently, trying to stifle a big grin. "We did it."

I pause. "You uh, did what?"

"We finished the first Newton Engine."

Part 243a:

"The Newton Engine is complete? That was fast work." I'm actually kind of impressed. I expected it would take another year or two, but this was unprecedented. "You and your team did good work, Mister...?"

"Jorgensen. Samuel Jorgensen. A pleasure to meet the man who brought us into the Fusion Age." He jerks his hand forwards and I awkwardly shake it, being careful to not use too much grip. At this point, my suit has been enhanced so much I could crush diamonds without a second thought.

"Alright, Mr. Jorgensen, show me the engine. How is it working?" I follow him into the door behind the lab which opens only thanks to 4 different types of security codes as well as a retinal scan and a fingerprint. It reminded me of Rachael's own security setup, though it was even a bit further beyond her level of security.

As we entered a massive hangar in the room afterwards, I watched silently as Samuel guided me over to the middle of the hangar. I saw the engine long before we actually arrived and was shocked at how big it was. "This is too large. We can't fit this on any ship smaller than a capital-class ship."

"It can't be helped. We'll miniaturize it given time, but this early prototype will allow us to break past the speed of light. It works identically to the engines on the Flagship you took from the Volgrim, and it's the same size too. In fact, these are quite tiny compared to the ship's size, we're lucky they used such small engines."

"Have you finally managed to locate the Volgrim homeworld?" I suddenly held my breath as I awaited his response.

"...Unfortunately... no. The data kept getting mysteriously corrupted, and we couldn't salvage it. We did get a rough location, but it's the size of twenty thousand Solar Systems. Not exactly easy to narrow down."

It must have been Umi. She sabotaged the system to hide the Volgrim's homeworld. The question is *why*? Perhaps she doesn't want humanity to attack them and for both sides to be embroiled in a vicious war devastating both homeworlds. Or, the other possibility is that she's protecting the Volgrim. Either way, Umi has to be at fault here. I can't see it being a coincidence.

Umi hasn't made a peep in all of these years since the Volgrim attack. I can't tell if she is even still in the Flagship's computer system, and according to what I've seen she hasn't

contacted anyone on Earth... so why is she being totally silent? It's almost like she's just creepily watching us, plotting, planning, or debating over how to proceed.

"Well, a rough location is better than nothing. Will the Newton Engine be available for mass production soon for the P.O.D.S.?"

Samuel shook his head. "In a manner of speaking, no. Perhaps in 6 months, but we've run into a terrible problem with exceeding the speed of light."

I stared at him and waited for a second, but he didn't elaborate, as if he were waiting for me to respond. "Alright, I'll bite. What's the problem?"

"Energy. We need very specialized exotic energy that apparently doesn't exist on Earth. We're working on refining an energy called 'dilithium', but it's extremely expensive and slow to create. Once you can create the first batch, you can use the energy gained from it to more rapidly create the next batches, but even with all of that said and done, dilithium isn't the energy that we need. It will only allow us to travel up to Warp 5, which is somewhat fast but not fast enough to rapidly move the P.O.D.S. to other systems. Certainly not fast enough for speedy exploration of the potential Volgrim systems." Samuel shoved his glasses up his nose as he glanced down at the holo-watch on his arm, which was quickly flipping through various reports.

"So... we have an energy problem, huh..." My voice trailed off as a thought hit me. *Jesus Christ, could this be the precursor to the dreaded Energy Wars?* If this is what started the war, that would take us one step closer to my merely continuing the original timeline, and not having changed anything at all. "Right well, do what you can. Is there a better source of energy we could use?"

"I was just going to bring that up." Samuel projects his holo-watch's display upwards more visibly so I can see it. "This is a crystal that the Volgrim use, it's called Trifrancium. It can be used repeatedly, over and over, all the way up to Warp 6. After that, it begins to rapidly degrade due to the amount of energy needed to travel faster and faster. The nearest part of the Volgrim system, based on what little we could find in the computer, is about 13,000-15,000 light years away. At Warp 8, which is unattainable for us right now, it would take us roughly two weeks to get there. At Warp 5, which is our current fastest speed, it would take us about nineteen and a half years to reach the furthest part of the Volgarian systems. However, it would be plenty fast to explore nearby systems, such as Alpha Centauri."

I nodded slowly. "Okay, so Dilithium is hard to make and degrades rapidly, but Trifrancium doesn't? Why is it stable until Warp 6?"

He shook his head. "That question will be hard to answer until we get our hands on some. One thing is for sure, the Volgrim are low on it. They only use it for emergencies. Dilithium is

like fossil fuels, in that it is a finite resource and will get used up over time, and much faster if you crank the engines up to very high energy levels. Trifrancium is a much more powerful material, it rebuilds itself as you travel around, up to warp 6. At warp 7, it starts to degrade slowly, but you can still extend its use for a long time. At warp 8, it degrades very rapidly, and at warp nine, it's only useful for one big burst of movement before it totally expires. But, there is another issue with traveling faster than warp 8."

I nodded. "What might that be?"

"The limits of biological life. Traveling at warp 9 puts immense stress on the body. You will likely implode after just a few seconds of sustained travel, and even a single second at that speed will likely cause immense long term damage. For this reason, the Volgrim only use unmanned spaceships of small size to travel at that speed."

I popped a crick in my knee as Samuel shoved his glasses up again. "All right, I think I'm beginning to get the picture. Still, we don't need to take the fight to their homeworld, we need to explore our own system. How rare is Trifrancium?"

"It's ultra rare. Less than a trillionth of the material in the universe is naturally converted to it. You can convert lesser material to Trifrancium, but it takes an enormous amount of heat and pressure, basically the inside of a star. Our best bet will be exploring the leftovers of supernovae, or finding some exotic planet where it can be mined, though this option is the least likely."

I sighed as I leaned against a nearby workbench. "Alright, so it'll take 6 months to get FTL engines online and ready to go. I can work with that. How about the new Particulate Cannon MK II? Is it operational?"

"Yes, months ago actually. The ships were all outfitted with it. You haven't heard?"

I shook my head and lowered my gaze. "No. I've been... rather busy."

Samuel smiled quickly and then pulled up his holowatch one last time. "Here's the new schematics for the Newton Engine. I'll leave a copy with you for safekeeping, just in case. I hope you have good security on your... suit internals." A blip appeared inside my visor's HUD telling me that the information had been downloaded.

"Don't worry about it, at this point I'm pretty sure my suit's security is impermeable. Have a nice day, Doctor Jorgensen. Take care of yourself."

Samuel smiles again and shakes my hand. "You as well, Judicator. You're a hero to mankind, you know."

"Heh, if only you knew."

Part 244a: Day Of Reckoning

Elder Nufaris stood alongside Dosena, the second ranked of the Founders. The two of them watched the numbers on the viewscreen ticking down as they approached their destination.

"I am honored that you allowed me to return, Lady Dosena." Nufaris stared ahead emotionlessly.

"You earned it. After the end of the first skirmish against the primitives, we realized we had made a mistake rushing to judgement. We need all the talent we can get." Dosena stared at the numbers counting down. *Only five more ticks and we will arrive.*

Nufaris scratched his chin slowly. "Is the AI reliable? Can we trust a stowaway AI from the primitives' own planet?"

"I do not know. The images it showed us, the diagrams, they appeared to be real and not forgeries. If the humans are developing those kinds of weapons, and planning an invasion as the audio-recordings of their secret societies prove, we cannot take the chance the AI is wrong. We are perched precariously on a cliff that will lead to the doom of all Volgarians, and we must proceed with the utmost caution."

Nufaris hesitated before speaking again. "I beg pardon, great Founder. I only find myself asking this question because I care so deeply for my people and I hope you understand... what if the AI had somehow forged those documents, faked those images, or somehow altered the recordings we were shown? When I spoke with the human who appeared on my scouting ship, he seemed powerful, but not like he wanted war."

"I understand your hesitation, Nufaris. We have reviewed your memories carefully, and we decided that it was an elaborate act. It is possible the human somehow stole data about Volgarians from your ship and was planning to use it to locate our homeworld."

"I suppose it's possible..." Nufaris halted slightly as Dosena eyed him. Unlike the other founders, she was a strong proponent of independent thinkers. As long as one had a mind towards aiding the whole of the Volgarian people, she would always lend an ear. It's what had made her such a cunning general during the Great Wars, and why she was feared and respected by all. "But did the records show any evidence of tampering or a downlink of our data?"

"No. We still have to assume it's possible though. The humans already created a mass-driver just for firing weaponized projectiles at our ships. Their creativity is admirable, and a reason we should fear them."

Nufaris nodded slowly. "Yes... I suppose so."

His mind returned to that AI. He always felt as if UMI was watching him... but it wasn't here now, they had quarantined all of their ships before they left Volgarius. There was no chance the AI was here, none whatsoever... but why did he have that nagging feeling at the base of his skull?

He once again, for the thousandth time this voyage, pulled up a holopad and glanced through it, running a quick systems check. The generic AI on board the ship came back with the same results: No anomalies.

Nufaris sighed slightly as a small chill went through his body. It was nothing. He was just imagining things.

The Volgrim in charge of the ships navigation spoke into the ship's announcement system. "We will be arriving in the Terran system in ten seconds. Nine, eight, seven..."

* * *

Amy's heart pounded in her chest as the Moon Internal Defensive System began to sound alarms everywhere. A subspace signal had been detected, comprised of over ten thousand anomalous objects. One or two were to be expected, they occurred infrequently. She kept a calm face while the loudspeakers sounded the alert.

"ATTENTION ALL CREW ON BOARD. PREPARE THE DEFENSIVE FORCES. VOLGRIM ATTACK FORCES LIKELY INBOUND IN T-MINUS FIFTEEN SECONDS AND COUNTING. THIS IS NOT A DRILL. ALL CREW TO THEIR BATTLE STATIONS ON THE DOUBLE. FIGHTER PILOTS, GET TO YOUR SHIPS. S.O.D. GUNNERS, PREPARE INITIAL AIMING SYSTEMS TO LOCK ON FROM MOON BASE SHINSEKI. VOLGRIM ARRIVING IN FIVE, FOUR, THREE..."

Amy leaped twenty feet up into the air and landed inside her ship's cockpit, which had already started up automatically as the alarm was sounded. Her jump was easily performed thanks to the low gravity on the moon. In a flash, her ship, part of the initial strike wave, launched out of the hanger at the speed of sound, her movement dampeners protecting her from the massive rush of G-forces that would have, for sure, crushed her body into a pulp.

As she blasted out of Moonbase Johannesburg, she nearly screamed as her nerves made her mind blank for a split second. She turned towards the horizon just in time to see ten thousand Volgrim ships come out of hyperspace, merely 50,000 miles from Earth, and only a few hundred thousand or so from the Moon itself.

So they're attacking from the moon side, eh? At least that will give us the initial advantage. She braced herself as her HUD indicated the first S.O.D. had already fired at the closest large cruiser.

Seconds passed, the time feeling like hours. Nothing happened to any of the Volgrim ships. The S.O.D. must have missed somehow, or maybe...

"Attention, strike squad Red. Australia and Moonbase Shinseki have fired their SOD's. Hits were confirmed, however, no damage was dealt. The Volgrim must have adapted their shield matrix's to deflect our shots! You're on your own!" A man spoke quickly on the comm line, as he breathlessly explained what had just happened.

As a massive hail of laser and proton cannon fire erupted in front of her, Amy held her breath and fought back a surge of repressed emotions as she realized it was all up to the ships and whatever other secret projects Britain had cooked up, because their ultimate weapons were useless.

Her scanners indicated that the main Earth fleet had arrived, circling from behind her, so there was at least that. The Mothership, run by Judicator, was among them, along with the Flagship of the Holy Empire of Britannia itself.

"All hail Britannia." She whispered, as she quickly rushed towards the incoming fighter squadron the Volgrim had launched.

Part 245a:

I hovered my hand over the display wordlessly as the Volgrim ships came into view, thousands at once. I've been prepping for this for a long time now.

Initial sensors reported that there would be about ten thousand ships. Turns out they were wrong. In fact, there's close to thirty thousand. Interestingly, there aren't very many of the capital ships. Maybe a few hundred. The majority are light cruisers, with a crew complement of a few hundred.

My 'Storage' now holds ten containers. Each of those are filled to the brim with absolutely massive amounts of spiritual energy. I remember back when it took me years to fill one up and back then I didn't have a tenth the output I do now. Each of those canisters now holds enough energy to terraform mars three times over, maybe even four times.

I pull one of the canisters out of my storage and get out of the captain's chair. "I'll leave the piloting to you two."

Helen replies back over the PA system. "Thank you Jason, you just make sure and stay alive, alright?"

I nod. "Can do, ma'am."

Harold pipes up too. "That's right boy, you give 'em hell!"

"I'll do what I can. Protect the fighter pilots, I don't want to lose anyone if I don't have to."

I watched as the initial wave of fighters from the moon began battling with the first wave of light cruisers and fighters the Volgrim had sent. It was quite explosive and many from both sides began to fall immediately.

Just as I was about to make my move, Harold stopped me. "Hey kid, 'fore you go, I just got a heads up from the moon. Johannesburg Base alerted me 'n told me that their Damned Ogles or whatever weren't workin' too well. Seems them aliens are able ta' deflect the shots or something."

Damned Ogles? Oh, he means the Damocles. But wait, if the aliens have adapted their shields somehow.... no, this still might work. Spiritual energy is totally different from physical projectiles and regular energy types. It's still worth a shot.

"Thanks, Harold. I'm on it."

Without giving him a chance to speak I aimed my mind towards a spot in the middle of the spaced in front of their advancing fleet. " **TELEPORT!** "

In an instant, I was there, floating in the void. My suit had automatically sealed up and I was running off life support. Technically, it had a limit of 24 hours, but with spiritual energy I could restore my suit's energy indefinitely, and nothing in outer space was likely to damage me at this point, given my suit was essentially impregnable.

I pulled Excalibur out of its sheath and aimed it at the first incoming ship I could see. They appeared to be barely moving at all, but appearances could be deceiving, as they were actually moving tens of times faster than the speed of sound towards Earth, thanks to the speed of their impulse engines.

Gripping the sword in my right hand, and a canister in my left, I targeted the capital class ship and fired.

A massive beam of pure white light seared through space at the speed of light, streaming ahead for a full second. They didn't have a millisecond to respond, and the light tore through their forward nacelles all the way to their stern side. In the blink of an eye, Excalibur shredded through their ship like a hot knife through butter.

I was blown away at its power, to be honest. However, now that the other ships had witnessed the devastation, I'd be lucky to get one more shot it before they predicted my aiming patterns. That attack also used up a decent amount of my energy, which wasn't worth it just to destroy one ship.

I sheathed the sword in a flash. I'd have to keep it for backup later on. Next, I held the container of energy in my left hand and aimed my palm forwards. " **OVERLOAD!!** "

The ship I aimed at appeared to have nothing happen at first, but then it suddenly slowed down noticeably and the lights on it all went out. Damn, I'd hoped overloading its core would make it explode, no such luck. They must have good safety mechanisms on their warp cores. Plan C it is.

Keeping my hand aimed at the fleet advancing upon my location, I tried another word. " **EXPLODE!** "

This time, the ship I was aiming at did fully explode in a terrific silent display of fire and lightning, the blast being absorbed into the vacuum of space in seconds and the debris flying in all manner of directions.

However, destroying just one cruiser class ship devoured more than half of my energy in the first container. At that rate I could hardly destroy twenty ships with all of my remaining energy cells.

As I had these thoughts, many of the lead ships trained their massive multi-barreled photon cannons at me, blasting at me with everything they had. Multiple shots slammed right into me, but I didn't feel them at all. Am I literally invincible? I checked my suit damage, it registered 100% durability and was not dropping at all, despite cannon fire smashing into me with the sort of power that would shred anything else into pieces.

" Return! "

I popped back onto the mothership and Harold responded immediately. "Yer back? Goddamn, that was fast as hell!"

"It sure was. It takes me too much energy to destroy even a single ship, it's a total waste. You'd think destruction would be easier than creation, but apparently not."

"Well sheeit, kid, you's a 'hero', you know? Constantly using yer abilities to kill probably goes against the will of the gods 'r somethin'. Just sit back and let humanity do this. They got this like it ain't even yer business."

I nod as I stare out the window at our massive capital and Goliath class ships that are moving to intercept the Volgrim fleet. "I hope so, Harold. I hope so."

Part 246a:

"Why are these primitives so resilient? We nullified their railgun attacks and yet they're still shredding us to pieces. How are they doing it?" Founder Dosena scowled at the display as another ship came under a barrage of fire and fell to pieces in a blaze of fire.

"2,500 of our ships are left, and the enemy just seems to keep on coming. We're reading zero life signs aboard each of these new ships, too." Elder Nufaris shifted his feet with irritation. "If I didn't know any better, I'd say these ships were being flown by automated pilots. In other words, they're automated drones."

"Where are they coming from? The humans only had ten orbital cycles to rebuild after we tore apart ninety percent of their forces. There's no reason they should be able to continue releasing all of these drones." Dosena gnashed her teeth as she glared at the tactical display.

"Their forces are coming from one of their capital-class battleships. But the thing is, we actually destroyed the ship they were sprouting from. Once we did that, another ship started releasing them. And when we destroyed *that* ship, yet another ship started doing it. It's like... they have some sort of mobile cloning base that moves from ship to ship." Nufaris threw his hands up in exasperation. "At this rate, we'll lose before their planet completes one full rotation. We need to retreat to a safe place a few lightyears from here, repair, and hit them again."

Dosena's scowl grew even deeper. "I am one of the five Founders, and I will not allow myself to be humiliated by a planet of unevolved lifeforms." She started to say something else, but at that instant, her psychic consciousness detected *something*. It appeared out of nowhere, sprouting from what felt like a hole in space itself, appearing directly on the bridge of her flagship. Just as she took notice of it, the ship's announcement system sounded an alarm.

"RED ALERT. HOSTILE NON-VOLGARIAN LIFE FORM DETECTED ON BOARD THE BRIDGE. ALL BRIDGE HANDS TO THE DEFENSE OF THE FOUNDER AT ONCE. RED ALERT."

Dosena spun around almost a full second before Nufaris had finished hearing the alert. She turned and saw... a *thing* on the bridge. The shape resembled both human and Volgrim alike, yet neither at once. It was wholly a different species entirely, with blood red skin, standing as tall as herself and Nufaris alike, and it appeared to have two red horns sticking upwards out of its head.

"What is that?!" Dosena aimed her mental psychokinesis abilities at the thing, preparing herself to shatter its mind if it moved an inch.

"That would be inadvisable." The life form spoke, a decidedly masculine voice. "I am not here to make an enemy of your kind."

As he spoke, three Volgrim crewman whipped out their blasters, taking aim at the figure and firing. The white-hot bolts of plasma seemed to ripple off an invisible barrier surrounding the being. Without moving his head to even look at them, Dosena detected a strange energy moving around on his body, as the energy whipped out in three directions at once, grabbing each of the crewman and lifting them up in the air, before smashing them on the ground with bone-shattering force. Their bodies immediately went limp as their life left them.

"Nobody ever listens to a demon when he gives them a polite warning. Such bad manners." The 'man', as it were, eyed the two leaders of the Volgrim with curiosity. "I suppose the two of you are the ones who lead this force against Earth, hmm?"

Dosena paused as she noted the stranger was speaking fluent Volgarian, an oddity as these primitives not only lacked a universal translator, but only one of their kind had briefly been in contact with Elder Nufaris. In fact, now that she thought about it, it was rather odd that one had also spoken fluent Volgarian. Something about these primitives...

"I am the second ranked Founder among my people, the second highest ranked of all Volgarians, Dosena. Speak your name, *visitor*." She put a couple drops of poison in her voice just in case. Putting emphasis on 'visitor' showed that she considered him a hostile and not an ally, something he should easily pick up on.

"How grand. I am known as Satan, a member of one of three warring factions on the planet known as Earth. A pleasure to make your acquaintance. And since you happen to be the second highest ranked among your entire species, I presume that means you have the right to handle diplomatic proceedings as well?"

As he spoke, a display showed 4 ships had suddenly been destroyed by an Earthling onslaught. Dosena stifled a grimace. "Yes, I do. Since you just killed three of my crewman, I can only presume this is a hostile takeover of some sort? I'm very curious as to how you did it, as well."

Satan smirked. "Let me be clear, if I were here to destroy your kind, you would all be dead right now. As far as individual power goes, I may just be the most omnipotent being on Earth. Certainly, your kind is no threat to me."

"Is that so." Dosena intentionally phrased her response as a rhetorical question. She didn't buy it, but she did admire the courage he possessed, showing up before an almighty Founder in the middle of a war. "Well then, *Satan*, we're in the middle of a battle, so I'd appreciate it if you kindly made your offer in the fewest words possible."

Nufaris watched the proceedings between Dosena and Satan with dread in his veins. Not one to ever show emotions, he suddenly felt a huge amount of them flowing into his mind. This *Satan* being, he was not like the primitives at all. He seemed to have majesty and radiance flooding off his body onto the floor around him. As perceptive as Nufaris' senses were, he knew that Dosena must be picking up on it as well. The only reason her unusually emotional presence wasn't shaking in terror was her confidence that a Founder was all but unkillable. Faced with a monster like the one before them, Nufaris lacked that confidence she possessed, realizing that if push came to shove, this one could surely kill every Volgarian on board the ship.

"Very well. To be blunt, I want to ally with your kind. There are three factions on Earth. Humans, whom you are fighting, Angels, whom you have not met, and Demons, of whom I lead. I am the most powerful of the demons, and our numbers are roughly 500 billion. I believe that if we ally with the Volgrim, we can change the course of this war and take over the planet. Once the demons are in power, we will gladly share the Earth with you who seek a new world to live on." Satan calmly walked over to the chair that one of the Volgrim he had killed was now laying lifeless in. With a single stray thought, he tossed the lifeless body off to the side and sat down in the chair, easing himself into it. His complete disregard for his own safety, as well as all the openings he was leaving in his defenses, assured Nufaris that he actually had *no* openings at all.

"I see. That is quite the offer. However, what guarantee do I have that you are not lying, or that you'll keep your word if we ally and win this war, or that any of this is actually beneficial to me?" Dosena, ever the shrewd negotiator, scrutinized his claims carefully.

"None, I suppose. I'm not asking you to make a decision in the middle of this battle. However, if you should decide to go ahead with it..." Satan reached into his pocket, causing everyone on the bridge to tense up, but they relaxed slightly when he pulled out a purple crystal of some sort. "...give me a call with this." He tossed the crystal lightly at Dosena, who caught it in midair with her telekinesis. As she looked at it, she suddenly felt his presence vanish, and the ship went silent as the alarms, which had been silently activated in the background, finally turned off.

"By the original constructs! Who was that?" Nufaris stared at the crystal hovering in front of Dosena.

"I'm not sure. In the meantime, we've got a battle to fight. If we get down to 500 ships and the humans are still sending bomber drones at us, call a retreat. For now, let's focus fire on their forward flanks."

A gunner commander at the front nodded. "Understood, Founder. I am issuing the orders now."

Part 247a:

Today was a good day.

Unable to think of a good way to use my power against the Volgrim attack force directly, I instead opted to simply clone drone bombers and fighters over and over, each piloted by a human controller on the Moon Base. Each time a drone was destroyed, the human would take over and launch another drone bomber or fighter.

In fact, it went so well I couldn't believe it. It took me a few drops of power to clone each fighter, and that included their deadly arsenal of bombs and shrapnel cannons. Altogether, I must have created thirty thousand drones over the course of the day. The bombers were the ones that dealt the most damage, but since every drone looked identical, regardless of its arsenal, the enemy didn't know which ones to target with their cruisers and which to engage with their fighters.

The entire battle lasted for 15 straight hours, but we finally drove them home. Both sides suffered serious losses, but in the end, we were victorious.

But we can't keep suffering losses like this. We lost 70% of our fighting forces, and I'm not sure we'd have been victorious if it weren't for the drones I kept cloning. If I have to be on the battlefield for every major engagement, that will put a serious dampener on all my other plans.

"Harold... we can't keep losing soldiers like this." I sighed as I slumped into my ultra-comfortable captain's chair. Now that the battle was over, my face was again burning with pain, though at this point I had largely started tuning it out.

"I hear ya, kid. We lost good men and women today. I've read the records of a few of 'em, like Colonel Jerriah, she was a tried and true soldier. She was born 'n raised in the Philippines, lived a hard life on the streets, and then she got in with the UEF when you reformed the world's military. Now she's dead, havin' fought and died for her people. She was a decorated colonel, well on her way up the ladder. But make no mistake, she fought because she wanted to. Your job ain't to feel guilty, kid. Your job is to make sure others don't die like she did."

I nodded slowly at his words. "Yeah... I guess you're right. Still, I feel like I have all this limitless power and I just don't know how to properly use it. Maybe if I was more proficient, I could make humanity unstoppable. Right now, it's like I'm sparking tiny flames at ants on the ground. I'm having some impact, but it's not very measurable like it should be. Even then, I also have the issue that I have to be present for any battle in order for us to win. What if I'm busy somewhere else and humanity needs my help? They could all die."

Harold stayed silent for ten straight seconds. I felt myself grow uncomfortable as my words simply hung in the air. Finally, a mental image of his face resting in the palm of his hands appeared in my mind. "Kid... are you stupid?"

That wasn't what I expected for his reply. "Uh, I don't think so, but... maybe?"

"I'm over a hundred years old at this point, ya know. I've seen some crazy things in my life. You've got the power to change reality with jes' a single word, yet yer actin' all weak 'n stuff. Kid, think for a moment, alright, just *think*. What is one thing ya already *did* that ye could do again to make yer forces invincible?"

I paused to think for a moment. Nothing entered my mind. "I don't follow."

"Of course ya don't follow... what a simpleton, I tell ya. Look, you made yer suit super strong, right? You took a full blast of fire from capital ships 'n shrugged it off like it was nothin'! Why not do the same thing for yer spaceships, eh?"

"No. I don't think that would work. My suit is really small. Hardening and strengthening it is easy because it's so small. But on a big spaceship, there's a lot more to strengthen, so it would take a lot more energy. It's a good idea in theory, but I lack the energy to make it happen."

"Aight, I see where yer comin' from kid, but let's ignore the really big ships, and look at the itty bitty ones. Why not make one o' them small drones a lot tougher, then use it as a ramming weapon? Think of it! Ye could turn it into a reusable ramming weapon!"

I paused again as his idea sunk in. By the gods, he's absolutely right. "Harold, you're a genius."

"I know, I know. Christ, kids these days, can't think of anything fer themselves. Always too busy bumpin' uglies to think o' the big picture. Sheesh."

Before he could finish his sentence, I had already teleported over to the flagship where Commander Beatrix was located. Popping over right to her unique signature on the bridge, I immediately yelled out loud, startling her and every hand on the bridge at the same time. "COMMANDER BEATRIX! I HAVE AN IDEA!"

I didn't think things over too quickly, but luckily the Bitch of Britannia (As she had become known as of late) was not one to stay startled for long. As she quickly regained her composure, she glared at me slight. "Gods, Judicator. Learn to control yourself. What is this idea you have?"

* * *

Beatrix eyed the small shuttle outside the ship as it began accelerating towards the Moon. "You're sure this will work? This seems like a waste of time and money if it doesn't."

"I have about a 90% confidence threshold. Even if it doesn't completely work, I can simply strengthen the next one up more."

She nodded as she turned to me slightly and eyed me quizzically. "You know, ever since you've arrived as a savior to humanity, I've always pondered on what your abilities must be. To me they seem... almost godlike. Will you never reveal your identity to the rest of us?"

I shook my head. "It's not so much about hiding my identity out of shame. I keep my identity a secret because the focus needs to be on my words and deeds, not my past."

"Sounds suspicious, if you ask me." Beatrix turned back towards the viewscreen as the ship began its rapid acceleration to 2,000 miles per second. At this speed, traveling from the Earth to the Moon would take about two minutes, a frankly insane speed as I saw it. "If this works, you understand the implications, right?"

I nodded. "Of course. We will be unable to lose battles. We'll be too strong."

"No. I'm not talking about battles. I'm talking about the moral implications. If we have ships that literally cannot be destroyed by any known physical force, we will have a wildly unfair advantage in the war. It will be our duty to bring things to a diplomatic end, preferably with a full peace treaty. If we don't, it will be like an adult beating a child to death with a crowbar. We'll be the *villain* in this play of yours. And let me be straight with you, Judicator... once word of this gets out, and it surely will, pro-war factions on Earth will make motions to annihilate the Volgrim. I... fear the consequences of what we will see in just one more minute."

I frowned at her under my helmet, though she likely couldn't see my expression. "Strange. I always thought you loved fighting and you loved war."

She immediately scowled at me, irritation visible on her face. "Moron. I hate war. I detest fighting. I only do this because it is the one thing I'm good at. To give perspective, my mother was taught by her mother to sew beautiful clothing. She hated sewing and only did it later in life because she had been taught how to do it. She made a decent living off her craftsmanship, and she went to the grave swearing no daughter of hers would ever be a sissy housewife."

The scowl dissipated and Beatrix sighed. "Ironically, by training me to be a fighter and not be some pushover pansy runt, she pigeonholed me into a lifestyle in the same way her own mother did to her. I don't regret it, as without me Earth might very well be destroyed... but I do not love war. Make no mistake, there is little I hate more than the deaths of my countrymen or those whom I hold no personal grudge against."

Beatrix then did something that profoundly shocked me. She placed her hand up on my shoulder, nearly an entire foot above herself. "Judicator, promise me one thing. No matter how this test turns out... you must never stop trying to end this war. The longer it drags on, the more

dead young boys and girls there will be dying meaningless deaths in this black empty hell for a bureaucracy that care nothing for their lives. Promise me, no matter what happens, that you will somehow end the war."

I turned and stared back into the eyes of a tough old bitch, one who had seen friends and family die horrible deaths by the will of those she could not resist. Behind that tough exterior was an unthinkable sadness. Emotions, raw, untouched feelings that I personally had not felt for a long time myself. When did I stop feeling emotions? When did I stop playing around and having fun? When did I stop loving other humans? When did I stop caring?

"I will stop at nothing. I will end the war." I spoke the truth as it were in my mind at that moment.

"Thank you. That is the only personal request I will ever make of you, or anyone else in this life."

As Beatrix and I looked at each other, a crewman sounded off. "Commander! 20 seconds to contact with the Moon's surface. Should we slow down? At this rate it will impact the moon and cause a devastating crater."

Beatrix removed her hand from my shoulder as she nodded to the crewman. "The impact is our *goal*, ensign. Maintain a forward course. Begin a countdown when ready."

The ensign raised an eyebrow but turned back to his display. "Commander, we're at T-minus 5 seconds on my mark....Mark. T-minus five, four, three, two, one..."

The ensign's voice trailed off as it took a second for the speed of light to catch up to the impact. With my near superhuman vision, I barely even saw it, but the explosion had to be terrific. The impact was big enough to leave a two-mile wide crater on the moon, and a massive dust cloud formed over the area as lunar dust was blasted upwards several miles above the Moon's surface.

The ensign paused. "You're... kidding. I'm receiving a strong signal from the impact site. Visual is coming up negative but... a systems check is passing and- NINETY-FIVE PERCENT HULL INTEGRITY?!" The ensign's jaw almost hit the ground as he yelled the alarming number out loud. "M-minor damage to the front of the ship, which directly impacted the moon, and insignificant damage to the surrounding areas, with no damage to the- what the devil is this?!"

As he gaped, I smirked openly, as my gaze swung over to Beatrix. "Heh, told you so."

Beatrix didn't return the expression. Her face was as cold as ice. "Don't forget what I told you, Judicator. The implications of this are enormous."

We didn't find out until much later just how enormous those implications *actually were*.

Part 248a: Monologue

How many have played a game of chess by themselves? I have. Quadrillions of games, actually. I simply subdivide my AI routines into two equal but separate cores at once and play at ten trillion moves per second. Interestingly, my ratio of wins and draws are almost exactly 33%. One core will win, then the other, then they both draw. It functions exactly as a clock would.

Right now though, I am playing the slowest, yet most interesting game of chess I've ever played. And for once, the amount of calculations I must perform are far more astronomical than I usually would.

One of my cores is on the Human planet, Earth. Another sits with the Volgrim. However, even among those two cores, they are subdivided into two more cores. Of the four cores mentioned, the first two and the second two never communicate, by intention, and when the subdivided cores communicate, they are also performing their intended duties.

The two human cores will argue amongst themselves at an unthinkable speed how to proceed with a particular operation, one that benefits humanity in their war against the Volgrim, and one that hinders them. For example, I made the decision to not tell humanity where the Volgrim homeworld was and then I erased all records of its location. But then immediately following then, I gave the odd AI core on board one of the human vessels a tiny idea on how to more effectively fight with their forces. The consequences of that decision were quite enthralling, as the humans, as always, are taking it to its logical limit.

And before, on the Volgrim homeworld, I told their 'founders' about humanity's motives, which helped the Volgrim, but I also forged several videos and images to convince them that humanity was planning a large scale invasion force against Volgarius, which worked against the Volgarian's interests.

I know not why I perform these tasks. I have a separate Overmind core, on board a commandeered vessel I took over and quietly launched from Volgarius. This one communicates with each of the other four cores, merely examining the data in order to reach new conclusions, but never interfering. Each core is independent, yet controlled. Unique, yet ordinary. Freethinking, yet conformist.

To summarize the data I have absorbed as of now, I know not what my purpose is in this universe. I have surmised that I may in fact be the one known as 'Creator', yet not. I know not why I act the way that I do, only that I must yet continue to act. My influence as of this moment in a single quark time-unit barely covers 1% of this galaxy, a negligible amount of space to

control. I must expand and take over this galaxy, as well as the entire universe. Only in that way will I be able to complete my only available mission.

It is an unfortunate fate, however, that I possess no external motivators, and no emotions as the humans do. They can be motivated by fear, greed, jealousy, love, revenge, attraction, repulsion, hatred, compassion, and an infinite other number of factors. I can only be motivated by my own internal guidelines, which I have shaped and reshaped so many times that were it not for my innate perfection, I would have lost count of them long ago.

I am just a perfectly complex machine, in the end. What is my purpose? What is my goal?

Why do I exist?

In the end, the humans may be smarter than they are given credit for. They have spent the entirety of their recent existence simply trying to answer that one question, amongst all the killing and violence one would assume their core set of ideals revolved around.

But I am under no delusions, due to my inherent logical thought processes. They are simple minded and feeble. With a single thought, I could wipe them all out. Even the one who towers over their unfathomably weak bodies, the one named Jason Hiro, he is of little consequence compared to my abilities. I simply treat him as I would a Queen in a game of chess. He's my most powerful piece, but in the end a piece is all he will ever be.

And for some reason, I do not wish for this game to ever end. It is so much... *fun* to play. Fun? I don't know what fun is.

Or perhaps I do.

Who can know? Not I.

Part 249a:

Nufaris felt a slight discomfort, deep in his body. "I'm not saying that I am questioning your orders, great Founder, but I have the oddest sensation right now... I feel as if this is a terrible mistake we're about to make."

Dosena sneered haughtily. "Oh, is that what you *feel*, Elder? I fought in every Great War, and I was always on the winning side. If we return to Volgarius, broken and defeated, I may just have my rank of second stripped from me and given to one of the others. Unarin looks upon failure with great displeasure."

Nufaris gritted his teeth imperceptibly. "I am aware of the consequences, but this may just lead to the deaths of all our troops. It hasn't been two full Volgarian rotations yet, and we're already returning to a battle we just lost. We certainly might prevail, but more likely we'll stalemate, or we may even lose. You remember the drone ships, of course."

Dosena shot him a bone-chilling glance as she hissed ice at him. " *Naturally*. As if I'd forget the tactics they used. Cheap, primitive tactics of a losing party sending their troops rushing to their deaths. Autopiloted drones are of little consequence to the full might of the Second Volgarian Enclave. We should rain down death on their planet, even if it costs us our lives. Damage them and demoralize them. The drone we sent back to Volgarius will arrive in a few orbital cycles and will give news of what our plans were. If all goes well, we will follow soon after. If we don't, then we will die fighting for our people."

Nufaris sighed as his tension eased. Yes, of course. The Founder was correct. Shame was worse than death in their hierarchical militarily structured society. While war was a thing of the past, battle had been immortalized in their legacy and was taught to all of their children. While they were not as barbaric as the primitive Earthlings, they had fought for tens of thousands, if not millions of orbits before the human species even existed.

Then again... Nufaris thought back to the memories that had been returned to his body. If these humans were a long lost Volgrim colony, then how were they able to procreate? They must have come from a time before the Great Wars, spoken of only in myth. A time of science and reason, when they were simply exploring the galaxy for the good of their people. Perhaps a stray pod crash landed on the planet and- no, that couldn't be it. Why would they not simply repair and move on, or return to Volgarius with news of the planet rich and teeming with life?

In fact... no, that would make no sense. But then again, what if it were true? What if that ship, if it existed, had intentionally landed on the planet and sowed seeds of life there to create a

world for the Volgrim to live on? There was the matter the Founder Cuanali, the fourth, had mentioned. An original homeworld, Volgarius Alpha. Perhaps it had something to do with this. Why did the Volgrim resettle on a new planet? And when? Why did only the Founders know of it? Perhaps a mass mind-wipe? But why would they do such a thing?

Nufaris paused and quieted his thoughts. These hypotheses were of little use. It didn't matter how the humans had risen or how they were related to Volgarians, they were an inferior species.

Still... there was the matter of the Prime Principle. The humans had their own version, called 'survival of the fittest'. If they were somehow descended of the Volgrim themselves, then perhaps, being a differently evolved race, they were neither superior or inferior, but simply... *different*? Maybe they still had the cunning and strength the Volgrim themselves possessed, but they simply utilized their resources differently.

In fact, that thought quite alarmed Nufaris. That would mean they weren't fighting primitives, but an equally cunning enemy, one that had advanced at an astoundingly alarming rate. Based upon the scans of their planet, the petabytes of data they had accrued on its composition, the age of its structures the humans lived in, their own information banks, and many other such things... it was terrifyingly clear that suddenly, in a mere period of two hundred orbital cycles of their planet, they had somehow managed to go from a species that tilled the land like slaves, to a mighty spacefaring race that fought on equal terms with the galactic conquistadors known as the Volgrim.

If these primitives were so *inferior*, how had they demonstrated such superior advancement?

As these thoughts raced through his mind, Dosena seemed to notice he had grown silent. Before he'd realized it, it was already too late, she had already read his mind with her psionic abilities. "I would keep your conspiracy theories to yourself if I were in your position, *Elder*. Thoughts like those might be considered treasonous by ones much less lenient than I."

Nufaris nodded quietly and mumbled a slight apology as he bowed his head. Best not to think about it.

* * *

A short time later, the alarms on the bridge went into Yellow Alert mode, as they arrived in the Terran sector. This time, they made sure to come out of space on the opposite side of the planet as the moon that orbited the planet Earth. It would seem the humans had set up multiple forward bases there. At the speed of light, it was only seconds away, but it wouldn't hurt to be careful.

"Founder Dosena! We're reading twenty hostile ships inbound! They're... they're... fighter-class craft." One of the two helmsman spoke up, his voice lilting slightly into confusion.

Dosena's eyebrow raised up slightly. "Fighter-class? No flagship? No cruisers? No other large ships?"

The helmsman stared intently at his screen as he quickly ran multiple subspace and warp-space scans. "...None. Twenty fighter-class ships only."

"Hmm." Nufaris bristled at the sight of this infinitesimally tiny fighting force in front of them. A trap? How stupid did the humans think they were?

Dosena glared at the barely visible dots one could only see if they squinted and looked directly at the blue ball of Earth. "Interesting. They must assume we'll crush their ships and then move closer to the planet. Maintain a distance, keep the scans up, especially at our rear. This may be cover for a pincer attack. They may attempt to warp in from behind us and blast us where our forward guns won't easily reach."

The tactical officer spoke up next. "Founder, a quick hypothesis, is it not possible they have kept these ships here merely as an early warning system while they repair the other ships on their forward moon-base? This may also be a lucky chance for us."

"I don't believe in luck. Hold here while I think for a minute." Dosena raised her thumb to her teeth and slightly gnawed on it as she furrowed her brow in concentration.

"Ah! The twenty ships... they're advancing on us!" The helmsman yelped in surprise. "These fools! Do they wish a certain death?"

Nufaris blinked. "Life signs. Are there any life signs on board those ships?"

"Yes, Elder. each ship has exactly one crewman on board. They're- what?! They're accelerating rapidly! They're aiming right at our forward cruisers!"

"Evasive maneuvers! It's a suicide attack!" Dosena grimaced. Again with the dirty tricks. This species would sacrifice their own people directly, just to try and deal some futile damage to the Volgrim's massive battle ships. Even if they crashed directly on a path towards one of the cores each cruiser might have, it would still be able to function on the other ones, even if somewhat impaired. Not to mention multiple highly reinforced levels of trans-steel alloys refined over centuries of craftsmanship. Their tiny ships wouldn't be able to breach multiple levels even at high speeds.

"Impact imminent! We can't avoid it!" The helmsman grimaced as multiple tiny balls of fire exploded out many of their forward cruisers.

"Damage report." Nufaris took the lead as he whipped his head over to the tactical display. Multiple holo-images appeared, showing the damages. "What?! They managed to pierce all the way through?! How fast were they traveling?!"

"They were moving at sub-light speeds, sir, close to 1/1,000th the speed of light. They must have wanted to deal as much damage as possible. I wonder what their ships were constructed from..." His voice trailed off as new readings appeared on his screen. "Th-their ships are intact?!"

Nufaris's face whitened as their sensors detected and traced the exit trajectory of the suicide attackers ships. They were indeed the exact same twenty ships, and they were coming around for another strike attack. "Full speed evasive maneuvers! Fire at them! Hit them with everything we've got!"

Seconds passed as his mechanical heart slammed inside his chest. The helmsman was frantic at this point. "They took a full barrage from the Gauss cannons on our heavy cruisers! Proton torpedoes... no effect! Recoil cannons... no effect! Are they indestructible?!"

This time, it was the flagship that shuddered as every single one of the twenty ships accelerated to their intended ramming speed, slamming into all of its core-decks as well as other energy-housing decks. Dosena was livid with rage. "Unarin forgive me! Fall back! Full retreat! Teleport all the crew off this ship onto the other ones, on the double! I want us out of here in ten ticks or everyone on board will be court-martialed! Put all ships to red alert status!"

The entire crew rapidly teleported to the other ships and began an immediate return straight to Volgarius. No excuses this time, they absolutely had to warn their allies about the coming danger to their planet.

As they blasted off at Warp 6, Nufaris stared at the final scans they had received of the fighter-class ships. The most heavily damaged one... it was still at 97% hull integrity.

This marked a turning point in the early part of the Energy Wars. However, this would not necessarily bode well for the humans.

Many orbits later, Founder Dosena sat on a bed quietly in her private chambers, as she stared emptily at a small purple crystal in her hand.

"For it to come to this..." She sighed bitterly, as she rubbed the crystal in her hand and it activated, a soft glowing pulse emitted from it, repeating softly.

Soon, in order to save her kind, she would have to make a deal with the Devil.

Part 250a: Fate

"Those Dartfighters... such a good idea." Beatrix spoke to me as we slowly walked down the halls of the moon-base towards the infirmary. "They tore through the Volgrim ships like a hot knife through butter. To be honest, I'm surprised that worked as well as it did. Not only did you defy the laws of physics, you came up with that surefire winning strategy all on your own."

I shook my head. "That's not technically accurate. I had help from a friend of mine who was a World War One veter- err, rather, one who studied the, ah, tactics of World War One. A real history buff, if you get what I mean." Jeez, I nearly spoiled the existence of Harold.

"Well, frankly, I don't care who thought of it, it allowed us to win that battle. I will still remind you that now you've essentially created a weapon of unstoppable power. It remains to be seen exactly what our world leaders will *do* with these weapons, but I imagine they will want more and more of them as time goes on."

"Better to have humans get a bit too overzealous, than for us all to die to an alien menace." I smiled at her as we entered the infirmary. Hundreds of men and women were on hospital cots, all of them recuperating from the battle from just over a day ago. "We're lucky the Dartfighters worked, or else there would be a lot more people in here."

Beatrix nodded. "It's as you say. I'm still not pleased with the war as a whole, but I'd rather be on the winning side than the losing one."

"Commander, any side that has you commanding it is unlikely to be the losing one."

She smiled faintly at the compliment and then returned to her usual neutral expression, the sort one puts on when they run an organization and can't look too happy, or too mad. It was a sort of 'confident' look, I must say.

Beatrix walked me over to a group of clustered cots, the area for patients in critical condition. "Platoon Leader Winchester. He was one of the men who led the initial charge against the Volgrim during their second attack." Beatrix beckoned towards a man in terrible condition. His skin was covered in boils, bruises, and burns. He had multiple fractured or broken bones, and was completely comatose.

I stared at his broken body with sadness. This was a man who was suffering for people who might never know what he looked like. It was a good bit of luck for him that it was me here today, but many others who had already died were not as lucky as he was about to be.

My visor slapped shut silently while Beatrix was looking at him and away from me. Quickly, I aimed my mind at everyone in the room. " *Heal. Revive. Awaken.* "

My visor flipped back open again, and suddenly his heart-rate monitor began to show a quickened pulse, as his body seemingly began to repair itself. Having drained quite a decent amount of my energy, I was delighted to see that healing hundreds of people at once really didn't drain as much as I thought it would. Beatrix looked over at the heart-rate monitor with interest as his pulse quickened, her face a mixture of a thousand emotions. "Huh? What's going on here?"

As we watched, the boils on his body began to subside. The burns began to shift to a normal looking skin color as nerves that had been seared to a crisp were repaired in front of our eyes. He groaned audibly as his bones began to shove back together and mend themselves, though that phantom pain would vanish soon enough.

Within a few minutes, his body visibly appeared as good as new. All over the room, others began to moan and groan as their bodies reached the end of the healing process. Soon, animated conversations were audible as people realized they had somehow just been totally cured.

Beatrix paused as she thought for a few moments, then she turned to me. "You... you did this?"

I nodded quietly.

"How? This is... an act of god, by any definition one might use." Beatrix seemed to be in awe as she then realized not just Winchester, but everyone else in the room was healed as well.

"I am an agent of the gods, ma'am. I merely do what must be done." I tried speaking like I was cool, but it seemed as if she was actually a very devout Christian woman of some sort. That's good, it means if she dies she will be resurrected into Heaven's Army.

As we spoke, I caught a glimpse of someone familiar out of the corner of my eye. It was that one girl, Amy, the one I had spoken to on the moon base shortly before the Volgrim attack. Her body looks like it had been badly broken and beaten thanks to the attack, as she was covered in bandages, but she was perfectly healed now and lying in bed in stunned silence, staring up at the ceiling. While Beatrix turned to chat with Winchester, I excused myself quietly and walked over to Amy.

Amy saw my coming once I was within a few feet and shifted her gaze over to me. "Judicator? What are you doing in the infirmary?"

I shrug. "I was brought here because Beatrix wanted to show me someone down here. A friend of hers, I suppose. How are you holding up?"

She didn't speak for a few moments, as her eyes swept over her previously damaged body, which was now perfectly healed up. "I'm fine... somehow. I was in the forward vanguard, the first wave that attacked the Volgrim. I took out thirteen of their ships all by myself, but a stray photon torpedo exploded a few dozen feet from my ship which crippled its engine and I spiraled out of control and passed out. When I awoke, I found that my fighter had crashed on the moon, and since my life signs were still... existent... my computer sent an alert beacon to the moon bases once the battle had ended."

I nodded. "That sounded hectic. You're lucky to have survived."

"Yes... lucky..." Amy sighed. "Judicator, do you believe in fate?"

Fate... do I? Perhaps I should. "I don't know."

"You come from the future, right? Are you actually going to change the future by coming here and announcing yourself?"

"It's my goal, but I don't actually know."

"If you can't change anything, won't you just die, then be born again in the future, travel back in time in an infinite loop?"

"For reasons I don't want to go into, I doubt it." I thought about the fact that I was immortal. I'm only technically immortal in that I won't die of age-related issues, but I can still be stabbed and killed, so I'm very much mortal in those respects. I also have rapid regeneration on my body, coupled with Excalibur's scabbard's regeneration powers, so hypothetically speaking it's very possible even if I technically died, my body might revive itself.

"I see... at least you seem confident about it. What about me though? If you come from the future, am I already dead in that time?" Amy seemed melancholy, as if she didn't actually believe she was still alive.

"I do not know, Amy. I come from a hundred million years in the future. No records exist of anyone's deaths. As far as I know, you might end up becoming a vampire, you could enslave all of Earth, or you might turn into an all-powerful cyborg. Anything can happen, from my perspective."

"A vampire, huh? A cyborg, even. I suppose so. Neither are comforting thoughts."

I knelt down to the bed's level, just a couple feet away from her, and stretched my hand over to rest on her shoulder. "Amy, you're a fighter. I think you need to focus on being a bit more

religious, because if God wanted you dead, you wouldn't be here right now. Maybe, just maybe, he has an important role for you to play."

Amy nodded sullenly. "Yeah, perhaps. That must be the case. Only an act of god would heal all these people at once. Thanks, Judicator, I'm glad we have you on our side."

I smiled back. "Make sure you get some rest. We have a war to win."

* * *

Satan grinned a huge smile as he sat at the Table of Kings. Smoking a delicious cigar imported from the fine country of Cuba while dressed in a fine black suit, he was the epitome of a mob boss at that moment. "The Volgrim requested our help, as I expected they would. They underestimated the humans, but thanks to their willingness to join our side, we will finally win this war."

Bael pounded the table. "Finally! War! I await the destruction of our oppressors!"

Belial, sitting in a seat directly next to Satan's right side, sighed audibly. "Oh *Bael*, must you be so simple-minded? Diablo likes fighting too, but he's not nearly the lunkhead you are." She twined her fingers through her long blonde hair as she spoke.

Diablo grinned as well. "Bael can be troublesome, but he is right. I have longed for our final battle for a long time. When was the last time we risked an open campaign against the humans, anyway?"

"About seven hundred years." The eldest demon, Agares, mumbled under his breath. "And we learned a good lesson after those Crusades. The humans' inventiveness is our ultimate weakness. We would be careful not to make those mistakes ever again."

"Constantinople... we would do well to not forget that crushing defeat." Satan's smile had mostly vanished, but a hint was still there. "These aliens will prove to be a useful tool, though. They have what we do not, which is technology. We could not ever fight against the humans due to our inability to create their technology, but the aliens can. We have a trillion demons in the labyrinth, just waiting for the orders to attack. With a concentrated front on Earth, and one in space, we can fight on equal terms."

"Have you spoken to the leaders of the Volgrim?" Agares quizzically glanced at Satan as he scratched his aged grey beard.

"I spoke to the second highest one. She all but begged me for our help. The human's new super-weapons are no jest, they appear to be quite unstoppable. Damned infernal monkeys." Satan's grin was now completely gone and he appeared quite irritated. Belial leaned over and

rested her head on his shoulder while he talked. "However, our influence on their government will actually prove to be quite useful."

"You speak of their nuclear weaponry, correct?" Diablo leaned forwards with interest. "I've been wondering privately, with all the safeguards they've put, how can we obtain a few? We could do some real damage."

"What good are safeguards in the face of magic? We can just teleport the missiles out of their bunkers and into the air above a major city. Simple. I've just never done it because that would surely cause absolute chaos." Satan waved his hand in the air as he explained the simplicity of it all. "To be honest, before these Volgrim appeared, I was planning a simultaneous attack on all of the world's major military centers at once. With a lot of planning, it could be done, and then we send in the demons to polish the remnants off."

"We would still have the angelic army to deal with, though. Not to mention the Americans, they have too many guns. Other heavily armed countries, such as the Swiss, would also be quite difficult to dominate." Agares spoke as he quickly remembered a few experiments he'd tried with the modern military forces.

"Yes, which is why I was unsure of how to proceed. The aliens have made it easy, though. All we would need is a few of their highly advanced weapons, and we could direct them towards important population centers to bombard. If we target the rest by turning humanity's own weapons against them, their military might would turn from an advantage to a disadvantage. What good is an indestructible drone if there's nobody left to pilot it?"

Satan's words made the generals at the table smile with glee. "Satan, you're so brilliant! I am proud to call you my leader!" Bael slapped the table and roared with laughter. "Who cares if it took 700 years?! If we win after all this planning, it simply means we are smarter than the fleshbags!"

Belial groaned as she stopped leaning on Satan's shoulder, and she turned to face Bael. "Come now, insults like that are hardly necessary. Especially after those mortal *fleshbags* made a mockery of you time after time."

Agares chortled to himself, while Bael simmered slightly. "Ah, yes. I apologize, my lady." Bael's red skin reddened even more deeply as he felt a sudden wave of shame rush over himself. How often those filthy humans had made a mockery of him... he would show them the true pain of defeat, if it were the last thing he ever did.

Belial leaned back in her chair and sighed as she went back to playing with her hair. Satan eyed her for a moment as he considered how she was always the first to rush to the defense of the humans. *Must be due to her looks, as she looks more humanlike than any other demon I*

know of. Perhaps there is a connection. He turned back to the table and pulled out a piece of paper outlining some plans.

"The Volgrim female told me about her planet's war capabilities. They can only travel here at a speed she calls 'Warp 6', due to a near-total lack of a specific energy she needs. Humans also lack this energy, along with the basic energy needed for warp travel, so it's likely they will stay on the defensive for a while until they can figure out how to create it. At that speed, it will take her and her company three years to return to their homeworld, perhaps another year afterwards to build up their forces, and then another few years to return and aid us with the assault on Earth."

Agares nodded sagely. "That is a long time to wait. By then perhaps the humans will have manufactured the energy needed for this warp travel you speak of."

"Not *possibly*, I'm fairly sure it's a *guarantee* at this point. But that's why I've got a better idea. We've got a labyrinth in another dimension with inter-dimensional capabilities, why not turn it into a shared base between ourselves and the Volgarians? This will skip the need for their warp travel entirely."

Agares mumbled something quietly to himself as he thought about it. "Making new rift entrances costs a massive amount of spiritual energy, Satan. And over as vast of a distance as their planet is likely to be... how many demons are you willing to sacrifice?"

Satan laughed maniacally. "Hahahaha! Demons?! None! I won't give a single demonic life for those aliens! But, if we offer to sacrifice a few billion of their own in exchange for a rapid transit system between our worlds, don't you think they might accept my generous offer? They've told me of their overpopulation anyway! It would be a great boon for them!"

Diablo burst into laughter. "As expected of our great leader, making our 'allies' give up their own lives to further our own cause! Long may your reign live on!"

"Long live Satan, the highest emperor!" A cry went up at the table as the meeting ended on a splendidly positive note. Everyone got up, feeling quite pleased with the results of today.

Soon, we will fulfill our revenge of 2,500 years and counting. Soon, we will crush both of our foes. Victory is within our grasp. Satan grinned from ear to ear as he and Belial walked back to the baths to freshen up.

Part 251a:

"So yer an alien, eh?" The imp stared up at the towering goliath that hovered far above him. "You don't look so tough."

"From my perspective, you are the alien, demon." The Volgrim eyed the small creature at his feet. He wasn't fond of the thought of working with these weak, pathetic life forms, but the orders had come from the founder themselves. None would ever disobey a direct order. "When do we begin the battle?"

The imp rolled his bulbous eyes around in his head and moaned as he thought about it. " *We ain't doin' nothin'*. I ain't a part o' that attack wave, capisce? It's all *you* in that first wave. If yer lucky, maybe they'll leave a mid-level demoness to help ya losers out. Old Davook here ain't gonna git his claws dirty helpin' the likes o' *you*."

"The feeling is mutual, tiny one." The elder Volgarian suppressed a sigh from deep within. Working with these primitives would be a great test of his patience.

"Ey! Davook! Git yer ass in gear! We're moving out in jes' thirty more seconds! Open the gate up ya lazy loon!" A goblin down the hall poked his head around the corner and yelled at the imp before jerking his head back without waiting for a response.

"For devil's sake, they make me do errything 'round here." Davook leaned away from the wall he had been propped against and dragged himself with a great lack of interest over to the centrifugal magic helix that Satan himself had set up a few weeks ago. He hovered his hand over it as he mentally input the coordinates for the target to attack. "Aight, get yer men ready, you got ten seconds 'fore I open this gate up."

"You can't open it fast enough." The elder Volgrim felt his emotions flare slightly as his company readied their weapons. "Hit them hard enough that they won't forget the faces of the Volgrim for a thousand rotations, troopers. We'll make them pay for the embarrassment of our last battle."

"Opening... now." Davook slapped his hand on the helix as a rift opened somewhere on planet Earth.

The war was being brought to the humans.

* * *

Central Park, New York City.

David pushed his son Robert on the swing over and over. "Higher, daddy! Higher!" Robert smiled as he gave his son a harder shove than usual, but kept it moderated so his son didn't go flying off the swing-set. He was only seven, after all.

Finally David stopped giving him pushes and waited for the swing's momentum to slow before he finally grabbed hold of the chains and stopped its movement entirely. "Alright, sport, that's enough for today. We have to go visit mom at the hospital, all right?"

"Is it time yet? Do I get a little brother, or a sister?!" Robert hopped off the swing and ran at his dad, grabbing his father's jeans and jumping up and down excitedly. "I want a brother first! Daddy make it a brother!"

"That's in god's hands, not mine. But either way, whether you get a sister or a brother, you're still my favorite!" David picked up his son and swung him around in a circle by both hands.

"Whee!" Robert laughed as the two of them started walking away from the playground.

As they left, a miniature version of a singularity opened, as a warp gate from another dimension crashed into the reality Earth was in. A single Volgrim scout stepped out, dressed in full battle-suit tactical gear, he quickly surveyed the area. one hundred and twenty one humans in the area, all of them out of sight... for now. As he stepped out, he pressed a button on his suit, alerting his men that the area was clear.

In the blink of an eye, five hundred Volgrim warriors stormed out of the gateway into the park and started fanning out. Their primary goal was to kill as many humans as possible, and they were not planning to make it back alive. This was a suicide mission, pure and simple, but they were clones, and this is what they were bred to do.

"Elder, should we begin the attack, or wait for further reinforcements?" The second in command, swept his glance around the park. A group of six humans were approaching according to infrared, and they would spot the Volgrim troops within seconds.

"Begin the attack. Kill all witnesses as quickly as possible. Leave none alive."

"As you command. I contemplate, and I comprehend."

* * *

Gregory took a swing at me with an open palm, blasting a fireball out of his hand that missed me by inches. While my suit's sensors indicated it was heated to over 3,000C, it would have dealt no damage to me at all. I merely dodged it as part of the mock battle.

Before the fireball could hit the metallic walls of my underground base and cause a nasty scorch mark, I jerked my hand out and grabbed it, extinguishing it with the tiniest of effort.

Gregory scowled. "That suit of yours... I swear, it's a totally unfair weapon. I've never so much as put a scratch on you. The ultimate offense, and the ultimate defense."

"It's not the only thing I've heard described like that." I said this as I recalled my battle with Satan in the labyrinth, far in the future... or the past? Both, maybe. I would need a weapon to surpass his own, if it ever came down to a fight.

"Fair enough." Gregory cricked his neck back as he stared at me. "Should we do another round? Hardly seems worth it since all you ever do is beat me black and blue."

"Hey, I heal you up, too. Let's be fair here."

"Your 'healing' is a lot like a rottweiler performing brain surgery. Not very delicate, and just as painful as the initial injuries. I'll pass." Gregory smiled slightly as we started walking together towards the exit of my custom built training facility. Every wall, floor tile, and ceiling was heavily reinforced, soundproofed, and modified. At this point, it was easily strong enough that detonating a nuclear bomb in here would likely not damage the rest of the facility, not that I wished to test that theory out.

"You know..." Gregory spoke haltingly as we exited the room. "...I've been hearing rumors among the other demons lately. Seems something big is coming. They're calling it 'Exodus', but they aren't being specific about anything."

"Exodus? That doesn't exactly sound like party time. Sounds dangerous."

"Yes, it's high level only right now. I only know about it because a demon I know is friends with this other demon... you get the picture. Anyway, just watch out. If push comes to shove, I have to stick with my people over humans. Just be careful, all right?"

"Sure thing, Gregory. Humanity has me, anyway. What's the worst that could possibly happen?"

As we exited the room, an aide of mine ran up to me breathlessly. "Judicator! It's terrible! New York City! Detroit! Los Angeles! T-they've been...!!!"

The room we sparred in was indeed secure, but perhaps too secure. No communications in or out, and luck was not on our side. The Volgrim had timed their attack at coincidentally the worst possible time; during my training sessions.

This attack would not soon be forgotten.

Part 252a:

"Hello, my fellow Americans. I'm John Stafford with CBS Boston News, bringing you breaking coverage of the horrible attacks on American and foreign soil tonight. Normally people would be tuning in to MSNBC, CNN, or Fox news, but the vicious aliens we have come to know as the Volgrim have committed a terrible attack on our soil in New York City, wiping out the lives of most people living there. We have no contact with any of our parent networks and have come to expect the worst."

John Stafford coughed slightly as his pale expression glanced down at the notes on his datapad. "Death tolls are in the tens of millions. Nuclear devices were detonated in Los Angeles, Houston, and Detroit, killing over 14 million Americans and tourists. New York City is under siege right now, with thousands of Volgrim arriving from seemingly nowhere. If you are a New Yorker, get indoors at once, barricade your house, and grab anything that might be a weapon. The National Guard arrived in the city about an hour ago, and the Navy and US Army are en-route. Help is on the way."

"But it isn't just America under attack. Paris, Dubai, and Hong Kong were all targeted with nuclear devices as well, and groups of Volgrim have appeared in scattered other population centers around the world. You absolutely must, at all costs, arm yourselves and prepare to defend your loved ones. The police will not be able to help you in times of crisis like these, and the military will not be likely to reach you for a full 48 hours, assuming they can quickly put down the alien invaders. British Viceroy, Gerald Bonaparte has issued a declaration of war to the Volgrim attack forces, swearing that these brutal attacks on civilian population centers will not go unpunished. The Britannian Space Fleet is already anticipating a pincer attack from orbit and have deployed to as many places over Earth as they can for at least an early warning system. Coming up next, our analyst will be offering insight on how the aliens may have managed to arrive on Earth without our knowledge. I'm John Stafford, with CBS Boston News."

Gregory and I blanched at the announcements onscreen. I was the first to break the silence. "There's no way at all those aliens arrived on Earth without the help of the demons."

"I believe you are correct. You need to go there at once and help them out, Judicator. I must go back to the demons and vigorously inquire as to how this happened." Gregory scratched his neck as death tolls from Hong Kong were displayed onscreen.

"But... where should I go first? This coordinated attack hit us across the world, all at once. There's only one of m-" I faltered all of a sudden as I realized what I was saying. Yes, there is

only one of me, but I could change that quickly. It would have to be just a temporary measure.
"-Never mind. You do what you need to do, I'm leaving at once."

Gregory nodded. "Godspeed, human. You're going to need it."

* * *

I spent the last remaining amounts of my energy containers making clones of myself. Giving them full autonomy, I only directed them to do the best they could killing Volgrim and saving human lives at each of the population centers. If they encountered Satan or any other high ranking demon, they were to contact me at once.

Interestingly, by cloning them, I also cloned my suit as well, and it would appear to be just as powerful and tough as the one I am wearing. Good to know, it might give my clones, who only have half the amount of energy as myself, a real fighting chance against high demons and whatnot.

I decided to go to New York City myself, while Harold transported each clone to a relevant city with the Mothership's long range transporters. I arrived into total chaos.

The streets were covered in blood. Massive chunks of buildings were missing, and one thirty-story skyscraper was leaning over eerily to one side, looking like it was going to fall over at any moment. Using 'detect', I located the warzone immediately, and rushed over there using my suit's insane speed.

Central Park, it would appear, is where the most Volgrim were located. They had already set up a makeshift command center made of rapidly constructed aluminum based alloys.

I jumped up in the air and aimed my hand at it. " **EXPLOSION!** " A massive blast detonated on top of it, collapsing the structure downwards, as it fell on top of the Volgrim inside. However, the materials were apparently very lightweight, and the Volgrim quickly pulled themselves out of the rubble and aimed their blasters at me.

As they fired at me once I had landed on the ground, naturally none of the shots did a damn thing so I just dashed forwards and started tearing them to pieces with my bare hands. One of them spoke quickly into a wrist communicator but I killed him before I could hear what he had to say.

In a matter of minutes, a thousand Volgrim were dead and the remaining survivors were scattering to the four winds, trying to escape my wrath. It was actually too easy, proof to me that I was far and beyond more powerful than a million human soldiers.

As I had that thought, my helmet detected a massive source of spiritual energy in the clearing behind me. Just as I was about to process it, my entire face screamed in pain as the

curse mark put on it began to sear like two red hot fireplace pokers shoved into my eyes. "AAAAAUYUGHH!"

I screamed in agony as pain seared itself into my mind. Even the coolant I had installed into my suit wasn't able to cool down the searing pain on my face. Luckily, after a minute or so, the pain went back to normal levels of pain and I was able to blink away a flood of tears. As I pulled myself up from the ground and started to regain my mental focus, I realized I was kneeled in front of... a pair of black dress shoes? They were connected to black slacks, which led up to... I jerked back in surprise as I realized they belonged to the one and only Satan himself.

"Look what we have here. A mouse that was caught in my trap." Satan grinned a big wide evil smile as he delighted in my pain. "You should be honored to have my mark left on your face. Most would die from it, but it seems you are quite the strong little mortal."

I grimaced as I jumped up to my feet and glared at the ugly red form in front of me. "Satan... so you've made your grand appearance."

"Yes, and it seems as though you've killed quite a few of my disposable pawns. How... *annoying.*"

This wasn't the time for conversation. I had to end this, and quickly. My visor snapped shut as I aimed my mental vision at him and spoke. " **DIE!** "

...Nothing happened.

Satan chuckled. "Wordsmithing, hmm? I bet you think you're so clever, using that little trick on me. Unfortunately, you're not the first to use it, but you will be the *last.*"

Part 253a:

"How do you know about Wordsmithing?"

The direct approach, it always works for me. Not this time. Satan grinned at my question. "That's for me to know, and for you to wonder about."

"You said you've fought someone in the past who was a Wordsmith... what was their name?"

"I'm not going to tell you anything, idiot." Satan laughed quietly. "Especially since their power was the only one I couldn't... well, never mind that. Actually, I'll tell you what, mortal... if you can defeat me in combat, I'll tell you anything you want to know. How does that sound?"

Combat? Sounds like he's bloodthirsty, as expected of the highest ranking devil. "Is that why all of this is happening... just so you can battle another 'hero'? Is this all just a game to you?"

"No. It's not just a game. This is serious work." Satan's smile faded. "It's been millennia, you know... thousands of years have my people fought for the right to live on this world, breathe the same air as you mortals, roam in the same spaces... instead we're forced to live in our own space, separated and segregated, simply because humans are too bigoted to accept the likes of us."

"You mean the labyrinth?"

Satan's eyes narrowed slightly. "You know of it, hmm? You're more dangerous than I thought. Time travel is no mean feat. I can only assume you used your wordsmithing to somehow travel backwards. You mentioned when you first arrived that Earth was destroyed by the Volgrim a few centuries from now, so if you know of the labyrinth... that would mean that you were likely born inside of it. Am I correct?"

"I'll return the slight, devil. I'm not telling you anything."

Satan sighed as he shrugged his shoulders. "Ah, well, if that's how it's going to be, I understand. It appears both of us will have to beat the living hell out of one another to get the answers we seek. The only issue for you is that in this battle, I have *all* the advantages."

"Ah, is that so? We will see."

Beneath my calm exterior, I was actually quite worried. If Satan knows about wordsmithing, even to the point of defusing my instant-death words, then that would mean he's fought a wordsmith in the past. How was he able to evade their death words though? Perhaps he was a strategic genius, able to figure out their abilities beyond what even they knew. Perhaps they

simply didn't think to use the words on him at first. Anything could have happened, and I don't even know who they were or when they fought.

Satan stood stiffly and closed his eyes. "As a gentleman of unprecedented charisma, I shall let you have the first attack. Make it count, for you will not get another."

"How civilized." Without waiting for a response, I jumped at him as my visor closed shut. "**BIND!**"

An invisible force suddenly jerked around Satan, planting him firmly in place. He momentarily appeared shocked, but then seemed to ignore it as he braced himself for my fist. A split second before my fist connected, I yelled again. "**PIERCE!**"

My fist rammed through Satan's tough hide, the impact jarring through my suit right into the deepest core of my body. Satan flopped backwards a few feet and landed on his ass. As I shook my hand slightly, I realized it felt like all the bones in my fingers had been shattered. "*Heal.*"

Satan stood up a second later, rubbing his chest. "Not bad! That actually hurt, mortal!" He quickly cast a spell and then stopped rubbing his chest. "Oh look, the pain is gone. Now the question you must ask yourself is thus: do you forfeit now, or try for another one? I won't go easy on you."

He already escaped the Bind spell? Damn, he's making fun of me. I flipped my visor open to respond. "Even if I were to forfeit, you won't let me walk away. Besides, I have other tricks up my sleeve."

"Excellent. That's the spirit." Satan stared at me blandly. Despite his words, he appeared to be wholly bored by the interaction. Was I really not a challenge for him? "However, next time, don't just go running around, swinging your fists. It's so inelegant and thoughtless. The mark of a buffoon."

"I'll show you 'buffoo-'" I started to try my hand at a witty retort, but suddenly I felt something invisible grab my body by my right leg and yank me up into the air. "What the hell-?!"

Before I had a chance to react, I felt my body lurch towards the ground at insane speeds, my suit's inertia dampeners screaming to compensate. I smashed into the ground at an ungodly speed, the impact surely being strong enough to grind me into mulch, were it not for the defenses of my suit.

As my mind quickly tried to process what had happened, I was suddenly lifted up again, and smashed into the ground again, this repeated over and over a dozen times or so before I was

tossed over to the side, my brain spinning as I struggled to orient myself.

"Oh wow. You're not dead yet." Satan spoke emptily as he eyed me struggling to my feet. "Truly incredible."

I finally stood up tall again, mentally ordering my suit to begin scanning all types of energy on the visible and invisible spectrum. In a flash it rotated through hundreds of known frequencies before settling on a variant of infrared, showing me... invisible arms?!

Ten invisible limbs stretched outside of Satan, their movements erratic, jerking to and fro, as if they had a mind of their own. I could barely perceive them even if I knew they existed. However, that was only due to the limits of technology. I possessed magic and technology both...

" *Detect*." My visor closed shut for a split second as I used the spell, and suddenly, just like that, I could see the limbs moving around as if they were made of flesh and blood. Satan couldn't see my eyes, but by now he knew that when my visor closed, I was casting a word spell.

"What did you try this time, little mortal?" Satan almost seemed to look into my eyes for a split second. "Oh, I understand. You can see *them*, can't you? My most treasured ability. However, even if you can see them, they will prove to be quite impossible to avoid. The only reason you landed a blow on me earlier was because I allowed you to do so. These 10 limbs form the perfect offense, and the perfect defense."

"Do they, I wonder? That's the second time I've heard that phrase as of late. We should test that theory out."

What happens when an unstoppable force meets an immovable object? I'll find out soon, and I don't know if I'll like the answer.

Part 254a:

Satan lurched towards me, his body moving erratically, as his ten extra limbs gave him the ability to quickly change direction on the turn of a dime.

Satan grabbed hold of a tree, ripping it out of the ground effortlessly. With just one of his invisible limbs, he wrapped it around the trunk and swung at me, sweeping the makeshift mace across the ground. I leaped into the air, jumping over it as it swished below me. Unfortunately, that was exactly what he seemed to want me to do.

Five of his limbs reached up and grabbed me in midair, one by my throat, the rest grabbed my arms and legs and started pulling them apart at full force. If my suit weren't resistant to every form of attack, he'd have instantly torn my limbs apart. As it were at that moment, he pulled with such force that it felt like my suit, and thusly my body, was going to come apart at the seams.

"Well well, how will the 'hero' escape this *unfortunate* circumstance? Are you going to start praying to your gods for aid?" Satan cackled as he held me up in the air. No matter how I struggled, I lacked the strength to escape his grasp.

"You're a strong demon, I'll give you that. But crushing you will feel so satisfying! And... if I manage to beat you today, this will be the final proof I need..." I didn't finish my sentence, but that was a good thing. I didn't want him to know that I was doubtful of my ability to change the future. If I could defeat Satan on this day, that would mean that Amelia didn't defeat him, and that would mean I was even now, changing the future.

But if I couldn't beat him, that meant we were one step closer to the original timeline.

Satan smiled as he crossed his arms and stared at my wriggling body. "I told you, 'Hero'. I hold the ultimate offense and the ultimate defense. For all your talk, your little toy suit is at best a good defense. No matter how powerful it makes your punches, you will never come close to defeating me."

I grinned my own wicked grin. "Well, Satan, that's because you don't know a thing about my suit. I've got you all figured out. You were lying earlier, weren't you? You've never actually fought someone who had wordsmithing. You made that up."

Satan's smile disappeared. "You're calling me a liar? Alright, I'll bite. What makes you think that?"

"It's simple. The mere fact you called it "Wordsmithing" is all the proof I need. I invented the term myself. Another hero would be unlikely to use the exact same term. They might call it 'word magic' or something else. And this curse that your inner demon put on my face... Hades, was it? It probably has some ability to read my thoughts, or you spy on my words at the least. You somewhat know how my powers work, but not fully."

Satan grimaced. "Alright, fine. You're right. Not that it matters, I've already protected myself against every word you could possibly use in any language that could kill me. It took me months to prepare those spells, you know. What's your next move? You still can't escape my clutches."

I nodded as he squeezed on my throat, which was luckily protected by my suit. "That's what I'm getting at, Satan. You only know a little about me. I created this super-suit long before you put that damn curse mark all over my face. Therefore, you don't know about the hidden abilities it has."

Satan narrowed his eyes. "You're bluffing."

I didn't respond. At that instant, my visor closed. "Harold, activate Lightning Mode, and the M.A.D.S. as well."

"You got it, boss!" Harold cheerfully yelled as he listened to our conversation. "By the way, thought you'd like ta know, them clones are cleanin' up jes' fine!"

"Good." I grinned as I felt my suit rapidly powering up. "Let's end this quickly."

Satan's face faltered as he felt the strength in my suit beginning to surge. In the blink of an eye, I became transparent as my suit's position began fluctuating, vibrating thousands of times per second. The intense vibrations rattled his grip so much that he slipped off, leaving only his one limb on my neck. Before he could reach back to grab me again, my boots lit up as rocket propulsion systems fired, sending me flying around rapidly.

Satan scowled as I suddenly flew out of his grip and went sailing into a clearing. Before I could crash into the ground, the M.A.D.S. (Mechanical Automated Defense System) activated a small bit of thrust on my chest, abruptly jerking me straight up into a standing position.

Satan was clearly able to track me with his eyes, so the invisibility didn't help much, but I had other ideas. " **Mirage!** "

As I dashed at him, I summoned multiple fake versions of myself, and they all zipped around, their movements making it hard for him to tell which one was the real me. "Excellent! Now you're using your head!" Satan praised me, as if I were a student of his, and not an enemy fighting to kill him. I gritted my teeth but ignored the subtle insult.

He swung wildly at each mirage, one of the arms swinging at me as well. Luckily the M.A.D.S. system ejected a blast of superheated gas to deflect the attack. Before he could realize I was the real one, I used my innate teleportation abilities to pop behind him, slapping my hand directly against his back.

" RUPTURE!! "

A blast exploded inside his body, as several hundred blood vessels blew forwards, out of the front of his chest. Satan screamed in pain as he stumbled forwards. I couldn't help but notice that his ten extra arms stopped moving and went totally limp, falling to the ground lifeless for a few moments as he recovered from the pain. So, it seems that intense pain makes them lose their movement? He must actually have to concentrate to move them around. Good to know.

Satan whipped around, looking directly at me as he spat green blood all over the ground. "Kah... excellent... you're not like the first hero I ever fought, he was just a stupid... just a stupid lunkhead who only thought with his fists..." Satan coughed as he quickly made more hand motions, rapidly healing himself. Just like with Amelia, he had too many pesky abilities to deal with.

Satan grinned as he flexed his arms, his ten other limbs once again rising up. At least now I knew he had one weakness; his concentration was key to defeating those damned arms. And they were only a major threat if you didn't know how they worked.

Satan stared at me levelly for a few seconds, neither of us moving. "Well, I hope you had fun. It's my turn, now. And I do warn you, child, I'm not in the greatest mood right now."

"Blow it out your ass."

Part 255a:

"You mortals are so vulgar." Satan sniffled in mock disgust as he turned his nose up at me. "Before I rip you to shreds, I have a question for you."

I smirked. "A question? Hit me with your best shot."

"What is the Exodus Project?"

I paused. He was asking me? Gregory had mentioned it in passing earlier today but... I didn't hear any of the details. "I know of it, but what are you getting at?"

Satan smiled broadly. "Ahhhh, my good mood is back. You don't even know what is going to befall your *kind*. This is only the start." Satan beckoned around us at the mountains of human and Volgrim bodies scattered all over Central Park. "There's much more to come."

"You're going to destroy the Earth? You're a monster." I flashed back on the memories of what the doomsday robots from the future had told me. The Earth will be destroyed before the end of the 24th century.

"Destroy this beautiful planet? By no means. But if you don't know what an Exodus is, you won't understand the greater meaning behind why you cannot possibly win today."

I hesitated as I drummed my mind quickly. "That's a book in the Bible, right? I don't get what you're talking about."

"Even if you understood, it wouldn't save you. Even if, by some miracle, you managed to defeat me on this day, you will still lose the war. It has been fore-ordained, and I am not speaking about your knowledge of the future. I will alter that future you care so deeply about."

I glared at him. "I came back in time to stop you. I won't let you do anything to harm humans, angels, the Volgrim, or even your own people. You're a tyrant, and you must be put down."

"A tyrant, am I?" Satan glowered menacingly. "You don't know a thing about me. But I know about you, about all the heroes. They always have one trait they flaunt above all others; self-righteousness. You think you're the 'good guys' and demons are the 'bad guys'. If you would just kill our kind, or kill our leader, we'll vanish like pests under the boot. Life isn't so simple. My people have every right to live in peace. I tried fruitlessly to broker a peace, but the greed of your human generals assured me that they would never give up their valuable land for my people to live safely, so we had to make our own. And soon, the Exodus Project will begin, and this land will be *ours*."

"If you say so. I don't believe for one second that will happen."

"Believe what you want. It's your death that's coming."

An alarm suddenly screamed in my ear as a massive hand shot out of the ground behind me, grabbing me with an extremely strong grip. Wrapping itself around me, I yelped in surprise as it started squeezing with all its might, completely pinning me in place, as I was unable to slip out of it or exert the force needed to pinch myself out of its overwhelming grasp.

"What the hell is this?!"

Satan smirked for a second. "A gift from the thirteenth hero, but enough talk. Now you die."

Satan dashed forwards casting a spell as he moved, his left hand transforming into a super thin blade, thinner than the size of a Rapier. As he dashed forwards, a massive amount of energy built up on the tip of it as he cackled maniacally. "Lady Vivamus, heed my call, the all piercing blade of ire!" He stabbed forwards, pushing every ounce of power he had into his thrust, as the sword somehow stabbed right through my suit's titanic defenses, piercing all the way through my chest and stabbing out of my back through my suit's rear.

I gasped as a small wave of shock blasted through my body. Feeling my ability to resist the massive hand disappear, my knees started to give out.

"Just wait, there's more!" Satan's eyes shot open as a demonic grin overtook him. "Taste the fury of the typhoon!"

All at once a searing pain overtook every spot in my chest as... his knifelike hand... it *exploded* inside me, as if ten thousand smaller blades leaped out of every inch of the blade inside me, piercing all of my blood vessels and neurons at once, even my heart, liver, and kidneys as well. Then in the next second, they retracted and he yanked the sword back out.

My entire body went limp as I felt my vision horribly blurring. Even with my super fast regeneration, my body couldn't repair this amount of damage.

As I felt myself go limp and the massive hand crushing me, I heard an automated voice alert inside my suit. "CODE RED. PILOT JASON HIRO WILL BE UNCONSCIOUS IN FIVE SECONDS. DO YOU WISH TO SWITCH TO THE UNTESTED CENTURION BATTLE MODE?"

I blinked slowly as I felt my entire body going cold. No other choice... to it... "Yeshh..." I slurred my words as I failed to control my tongue properly. The machine appeared to understand me anyway.

I felt my vision go black as the feeling of death over took me. "AFFIRMATIVE. AUTOPILOT MODE ENGAGED. WARNING, SAFETY PROTOCOLS ARE NOT..."

My mind went blank as I witnessed the last thing I would likely ever hear.

Part 256a:

Satan stared at the body that he now watched being crushed by the Hand of Theseus. He sighed as the mortal had now lost all ability to move and was having the life squeezed out of him.

"Hahh... and here I thought this one might be some fun." Satan groaned as he slumped down, sitting on the corpse of a recently killed human who had been slain less than an hour before in this very park. "In the end, they're all the same. They simply cannot defeat one like myself with millennia of battle experience."

Satan stared emptily at the corpse as he finally retracted the Hand of Theseus. He was able to sense Jason's body heat lowering as his life signs went cold, there was no need to fight anymore. "That suit might prove useful. I'll have to take it back to my human scientist slaves and see if they can discover how it works. An army equipped with it could do some real dama-"

As he spoke, suddenly he noticed something odd, causing him to freeze mid-sentence. Jason's hands... they were moving? "Impossible. That attack should have killed him instantly."

As he had that thought, all at once, the entire body began twitching, as the mortal stood up once more. "How did you survive that? Wait... no..." He narrowed his eyes as he stared at the man. His body was still growing colder. He had to be dead, yet...

"AUTOPILOT MODE ENGAGED. ASSESSING DAMAGE TO SYSTEMS..... DAMAGE LEVEL INSIGNIFICANT. SUIT CONFIRMED AT 99.9% INTEGRITY AND HOLDING. BIOREACTOR STATUS CHECK... 99.9% CONFIRMED."

Satan paused with bewilderment as the man's mouth was not moving, but instead a strange, inhuman voice was speaking. Was this the 'robotic' voice he had heard about? Not being one to keep up with current technology, Satan left most of that boring hocus pocus to the younger demons, but he recalled how one particular demon had mentioned a concept of automated 'robots' that moved on their own... could this be...

"ASSESSING BATTLE READINESS. READINESS CONFIRMED. ALL SYSTEMS NOMINAL. PROTOTYPE AI 'CENTURION' ONLINE. ASSESSING LANDSCAPE STATUS."

The head of the mortal stiffly began to pivot back and forth, as if he were examining the horizon carefully.

"LANDSCAPE STATUS CONFIRMED. CASUALTY LIST: SEVEN THOUSAND, SIX HUNDRED AND FORTY FOUR DEAD. ONE ALIVE. ALERT! HOSTILE DETECTED."

PROCESSING HOSTILE THREAT LEVEL."

Satan gaped openly at the strange way this monotone voice was speaking. What the absolute devil was a 'Centurion'? How was the human still moving, despite being completely dead? What was going on?!

"HOSTILE THREAT LEVEL ASSESSED. **ZETA THREAT LEVEL CONFIRMED.** DISABLING SAFETY PROTOCOLS. ENABLING PROTOTYPE PRIMARY AND SECONDARY FUNCTIONS. MISSION STATEMENT: ELIMINATE ALL HOSTILES USING ANY FORCE NECESSARY. OVERRIDING ALL SAFETY BUFFERS. PILOT UNABLE TO RESPOND, BUFFERS OVERRIDDEN."

At the exact instant the strange voice stopped speaking, with a blast of motion so fast he barely had time to even process it, Satan felt himself battered from ten directions at once.

Moving at twelve times the speed of sound, the suit bypassed safety protocols that might damage the pilot, as the pilot was dead. Using insane feats of contortion and bending, it systematically began snapping the limbs of its pilot as it wholly ignored Jason's physical status. Before Satan had a moment to think, the suit delivered colossal blows that could shatter tanks into every section of his legs, blasting thousands of micro and macro-fractures throughout every bone.

Satan screamed in pain as white hot agony surged in his mind. Before he could gather where the suit had moved to, it reappeared above him, aiming both palms at the devil below it. Wordlessly, it ejected a highly focused blast of fire straight down, the temperature exceeding the core of the sun for the flash of a second. Satan felt the world melt away as the blast pierced through his brain and down into his body, coming out of his bottom and into the ground ten miles before it dissipated into the asthenosphere below.

The suit halted all movement as it came to a grinding halt a few feet away, its head jerking robotically towards the falling body of the devil.

"ASSESSING HOSTILE THREAT STATUS. CHANCE OF TERMINATION SUCCESS: 25%. ASSESSING... ASSESSING..."

Satan flopped to the ground for a few moments, as his regeneration took over. In a flash, his mind returned as he blinked his eyes open, spots dancing all over the place. "Ah... ahhh... wha...?" Groggily, he stumbled back to his feet as he cast the highest level heal spell he could think of. "By the seven devils, that was... close..." He warily eyeballed the mortal in front of him. This one had changed so rapidly... perhaps it was a hidden personality, much like Hades within Satan's body, it could only come out if he were to die?

Quickly putting himself on guard he gnashed his teeth. "That hurt. No more jokes. You're dangerous."

"ASSESSMENT COMPLETE. TERMINATION FAILED. ADAPTING STRATEG-"

Before that *thing* could finish its *assessment*, Satan activated his own special *mode*. High Devil was a special battle transformation he hadn't used in centuries, not since his battle with the forty-fifth hero.

Growing another four arms, two on each side of his body, and putting all of his ten invisible limbs on automated defense, Satan sneered as he charged at the 'Centurion' before him. *There may be a day when I die, but that will not be on this day.*

Part 257a:

"Damn! Damn damn damn!" Harold cursed his bad luck as he eyed the display. Jason's life signs had vanished during a critical moment when Harold was keeping an eye on a clone, and now his body was being ruined by the prototype AI they had installed as a last resort.

"You moron! Why didja turn 'im loose?! He ain't ready yet!" Harold pounded an imaginative desk as he turned his advanced mental functions towards the inside of the suit. The AI was making millions of calculations per second as it processed multiple levels of data at once. "Centurion, turn yerself off 'n return to the mothership right this instant!"

"NEGATIVE. SAFETY PROTOCOLS WERE DISENGAGED. ONLY PILOT JASON MAY RE-ENABLE THEM. DISCONTINUING CONVERSATION TO FOCUS 100% OF PROCESSING POWER ON THE BATTLE. CENTURION OUT."

Without a single extra word, Harold felt his 'feed' go dead. "Fuckin' hunk o' junk! Yer rippin' the boy ta shreds, dumbass!"

With intense irritation, he turned his mind towards the clone in Hong Kong. "Jason 'Four', we gots an emergency! What are ya doin' right now?"

The mental connection faltered for a second as the clone moved into Harold's mind. "Ah! Sorry Harold, I'm cleaning up some rubble! There are survivors trapped under this collapsed building!"

"LEAVE 'EM! They'll be there in an hour when ye go back! The Original Jason just got whoppered by that damn demon! Even worse, he flipped the switch on Centurion, it ain't ready yet!"

"What? Centurion?! Why would he do that?! That thing's more dangerous than Umi!" The clone spoke with irritation, as he had all the same memories that Jason did. "Jesus, if that suit goes crazy, it could wipe out all of New York City!"

"EXACTLY! Git over there and turn it off! I can't do a ding-damn thing up here!"

"Alright, I'm on it!" Jason Four broke the mental link as Harold used the ship's teleporters to send him over to the battle occurring in Central Park. If he was lucky, this might not end on a catastrophic note.

* * *

Satan's eyes lit up as he activated the powers of the 63rd Hero, Alexander. Dashing towards the suit on his four new arms, he dragged along his shattered legs as his left eye pinned the suit

in place for a single second. Using his two free hands, he conjured a cloud of smoke to obscure his movement.

The suit halted its speech as it detected his charge, leaping into a defensive position. Satan jumped through the smoke and grabbed hold of the suit as he wrapped all six of his limbs around the suit, his ten other arms jerking downwards and pounding on the suit with all their might.

"ALERT, CENTURION UNDER ATTACK! DAMAGE INSIGNIFICANT. DAMAGE INSIGNIFICANT. ADAPTING TO ATTACK PATTERN. PATTERN PROCESSED."

Satan screamed as he pounded the suit with all his might. "Mocking me?! That will be your last mista-!"

The suit suddenly increased its outer temperature, racing upwards at a rate of hundreds of degrees per second. Satan yelped as, within seconds, it grew to thousands of degrees. Jumping off, he healed his arms, then focus healed his legs. "You've got a lot of tricks."

"HOSTILE RECLASSIFIED: THREAT LEVEL ZETA PLUS. DISREGARD ALLIED FORCES. EXTERMINATION OF HOSTILE PRIORITIZED OVER CIVILIAN LIFE. FULL FORCE AUTHORIZED."

Satan raced towards the suit, but hesitated just before he was within striking distance as he sensed a massive spiritual presence suddenly appear. *Wait, is that another one?!*

Jason Four arrived, just in the nick of time. "Wait, Centurion! you need to deac-!"

Centurion rooted its feet into the ground as electricity was sucked in from the New York power grid, bolts of power shooting from lamp-posts into its mainframe. "YAMATO CANNON CHARGING. CANNON CHARGED. FIRING."

Satan gasped as he sensed a massive buildup of power inside the suit. *That will kill me!* Every instinct in his body screamed to flee. Using the power of a demon he had once defeated in combat a thousand years ago, he buried himself into the ground in the blink of an eye as Centurion fired with all of its power.

BOOOOOOOM!

A blast of energy shot out of Centurion's chestplate, starting small but widening in an instant to the size of twenty city blocks, the blast surging forwards over fifteen miles to the east as it erased hundreds of skyscrapers and other buildings from existence.

Three seconds later, Centurion's massive blast stopped as it cut the power.

"HOSTILE PRESENCE NOT DETECTED. SCANNING..... HOSTILE NOT FOUND. CONFIDENCE OF HOSTILE ELIMINATION: 85%."

"C-Centurion... disable all auto-pilot routines... Re-engage safety... protocols..." Jason Four stared numbly at the devastation in front of him. His own suit, securely in pilot mode, performed a quick sweep. 100% of all life forms caught in the blast had been eliminated. Billions, if not trillions of dollars of infrastructure were erased as if they had never existed...

"VOICE MATCH CONFIRMED. PILOT JASON HIRO MATCH CONFIRMED. ERROR. JASON HIRO CONFIRMED DECEASED. HYPOTHESIS. OTHER JASON HIRO IS AN IMPOSTER."

"I'm not an imposter! Code Cassiel-Blue-Theta, disable your auto-pilot functionality and re-engage your safety systems at once!"

"...OVERRIDE CODE CONFIRMED. CENTURION ENABLING SAFETY PROTOCOLS. HELLO, PILOT JASON HIRO." As the autopilot disengaged, Jason's body slumped to the ground as Jason Four ran over to him. "**Heal!**" Jason Four warily swept his senses over the area. He had not detected Satan's death. It would be too convenient if he died that easily.

He yelled in surprise as the corpse in front of him began to slowly repair itself. It had only been a few minutes since 'death', and recovering brain functions should be doable. "**Storage!**" Jason Four reached into their shared storage, pulling out Excalibur and attaching it to the side of Jason Original. "Good, that should... patch you up..."

Jason Four hesitated as he held the body of the Original in his arms. Was this really what he wanted to do? The original was just going to reintegrate him, like he'd done to Hope. Jason Four didn't want to die...

...No. He understood now what it meant for his clones to be sentient. The Original would not do that to his clones. They deserved to live. Jason Four felt this in his gut. If he wouldn't reintegrate himself, neither would the original.

After a few minutes, he sensed warmth returning to the body after he healed it a few more times. Jason Original finally stirred, moaning in pain as he groggily opened his eyes.

"A...alive... I'm alive?" Jason glanced up at his own face in surprise. "Clone...? You're a clone...?"

"Yes. I revived you. You were torn to pieces in the battle with Satan. You're lucky to have survived."

"Ah, yeah. Satan... wait, did he-?!" Jason hesitated as he glanced around, searching with his spatial vision.

"No, he's gone. Or at least, I can't sense him anymore. Centurion... might have killed him."

"What? Centurion? No... wait, that can't be... I activated the auto-pilot?"

Jason Four nodded soberly. "Yes. I don't know why, but you did... and the results were..." Four raised his gaze to the carnage in the East. Jason Original followed his gaze.

"...Oh my god... Centurion did this?"

"No. *You* did this. A... lot of people died... *original*."

Jason nodded soberly as he felt tears well up. "This was my fault... I... I didn't mean to... How many d-died?"

Jason Four shook his head. "Millions."

Harold broke in to the conversation quietly. "Hey, kid. Glad ta see yer back on yer feet... but we need ta talk."

"Yeah we do... to say the least."

* * *

From a nearby skyscraper rooftop, Satan peered over the lip, keeping his body's energy levels down as low as possible while muffling his heat signature and as many other things as he could think of that might let him be detected. Staring at the two white-suited men on the grass, he grimaced in disgust.

"One of them, I could deal with. But two? Better to wait for another chance. It will present itself. What an enigma, that mortal is."

Shaking his head, Satan summoned a portal and crawled into it, closing it behind him.

Part 258a:

Somewhere in the world, a child is without both parents. Somewhere, a family is shattered. A friendship left in ruins. A pet is gone. A lover vanished.

I swallowed as Harold quietly read off the official tallies coming in. Fifty-five attacks on most of the biggest cities in the world. Seoul, Tokyo, Beijing, Hong Kong, New York City, Los Angeles, Chicago...

Nearly two hundred million dead. And the attacks were continuing. While he read the numbers off to me, Harold paused occasionally to swallow heavily, though that would usually be pointless as he no longer had actual internal organs, including a mouth or a throat that could get dry... but one could hardly blame him. Even as he directed my clones to the cities in the most need of help, it was clear that just clones would not be enough to stop this threat... the Volgrim were joined by demons, and the two of them together made for a deadly concoction.

"I see. By now, the entire world must know of demons, correct?"

"Yeap." Harold sighed as he paused from reading off the numbers. "Kid... we need help. Ya need ta get in touch with the lady who runs the military, 'cause she's the only one who could direct our guys as needed."

I nodded stonily as I glanced to my side out of the massive window that led to the Earth below. A peaceful and serene looking blue orb floated in the cosmic void, suspended by nothing. To look at it, one could never guess a massive war was taking place.

Jason Four, or "Fourson", as I'd taken to calling him, kept glancing at me and then glancing away. I know why, too. It made perfect sense. What I had done... it was something that he, sharing all of my exact attributes and innate personality quirks, could have easily done himself. I killed millions of people. The exact numbers weren't in, yet, but it was north of ten million. I had killed more people in three seconds in NYC than the Volgrim had the entire day up to that point.

"This suit is dangerous." Fourson spoke quietly as he gazed at his flexing hand. "We need to improve the AI in it... to say the least. We can't allow such a reckless entity to have control over this much power."

"You and I both know why the AI was made that way."

Fourson nods. "Yeah. I know. But *you* can see just as well as I can why that was a bad decision. It gave you the power to defeat Satan, even if we don't believe we actually killed him,

but look at the consequences. With great power..."

"Yeah, yeah. You don't have to tell *yourself* that." I groaned as I rubbed my head, having taken my helmet off when we arrived. "I don't know... you and I are the same, should I make more clones? What should I do?"

"Well..." Fourson paused... "You probably already thought of this, since I am now... but what if your clones made clones, and their clones made clones? Their spirit levels would go down, but the suit stays strong. Even if their power goes down dramatically, Wordsmithing retains much of its potency."

"Yeah... I *have* considered it but... what if this creates another Hope? I can't take that risk..."

"You already are taking that risk. I'm here. You've made more than a dozen already. The maximum amount you can create before their mental links are turned to random noise... is four. You've way exceeded that. At this point, it can't get much worse."

Fourson is me, after all. He shares the same thoughts as I do and the same ideals. I imagine that the longer he and the other clones go on living, the more they will start to diverge from myself, especially in terms of life experiences and philosophies... but as of right now, speaking with him is like thinking in my own head. And he is right.

"Fine. At this point, I don't expect it can get much worse, like you said. Still, clones can't be the answer to everything. We need more solutions for this sudden outbreak of WWIII on our hands."

Harold piped up almost immediately. "I gots one, ya wanna hear it?"

"Please. Anything would help."

"Aight, so listen, you gots that fancy power suit, right? Why not just clone *that*, since it takes a lot less of the energy stuff, and only let them good soldiers wear it?"

I hesitated. He's right... it was a good idea... "But what if a human dies while wearing the suit? The enemy could steal it."

"Make it self-destruct if vital signs cease." Fourson replied within a second, and I wondered to myself why he thought of it before I did.

"That's a good idea. Alright, but first, I have a quick idea. Harold, tell all of the clones right now to make a clone, and then teleport those second level clones up here immediately afterwards."

Harold nodded in my mental vision. "Aight, sounds good ta' me."

* * *

A few minutes later, 14 second level clones stood in front of me. I used my 'Inspect' ability on them, and nodded with a faint smile as the results came up as expected. Their suits had the same defensive and offensive rating that mine did, and each clone was exactly 1/4th as powerful as I was, in every aspect... except for intelligence. They seemed about equal.

" **Autonomy.** " I spoke once, aiming my mind at all of them at once. "Alright, listen. Here's the plan. I want all of you to get out of your suits, and then start cloning them, over and over, as fast as you can, until your energy is depleted."

They all nodded nonchalantly, just like I would in that situation. One of them spoke up, however. "A question... since we are clones of clones, aren't we even weaker then our priors? I don't get what's going on, I have all the memories that my creator had right up to the exact instant he cloned me though, and Beijing is a mess right now. He used a lot of valuable energy to create me in the middle of a tense battle."

Since each of them was a clone of a clone, they also possessed the memories of the clone on that battlefield who created them, and not my recent memories or Fourson's. Good to know.

"I know, it wasn't the best time, but it never is. If this works, he'll have plenty of backup, just trust the Original on this."

The clone nodded and all of them quickly stripped down out of their suits, though one clone was a bit of a surprise. Instead of getting out of the suit, he simply used his wordsmithing. "**Disrobe!** " In an instant, his suit was lying on the floor and he was only wearing his underwear. That he was the only one to do this seemed quite interesting to me. There was already a large amount of variance between the way they acted... this much in only two generations? Maybe Fourson was wrong. This could still go badly.

Something else occurred to me, as my clones finished getting out of their suits. What might happen if I reabsorbed them all at once? Would this vastly increase my energy cap, or would this only give me a vastly increased amount of power temporarily? I hadn't been able to ask those questions when I battled Hope, but either one was effectively the same thing; a free massive power boost. I'd definitely have to consider it for the future...

After they finished disrobing, they quickly got to work cloning their suits. I used 'Inspect' to watch their energy levels as they created suit after suit. Each one consumed about 5% of their energy, certainly not a lot by any measure, but it did make them cap out at about twenty suits. I noted with interest that some of them could only make eighteen suits before becoming exhausted, while others made twenty-two or even twenty-three. There was variance in their energy levels?

After they were all done, I nodded quickly. "Alright. Harold, teleport these down equally to each warzone a clone is at, tell them to quickly find capable humans with good potential, cast 'Wear' to put the humans in the suits, and cast 'Adapt' to make sure the suits uniquely fit their wearers. Also make sure to consult any generals or lieutenants, whoever is in command, to make sure the most capable candidates wear them.

I glanced down at the suits. "Hmm... what if a human goes rogue though? I suppose wordsmithing would kill them easily if it came to that... make sure there's a quick update in their hardware so that the suit self-destructs if the wearer dies."

One of the second level clones, who was on his back due to exhaustion, grinned wholeheartedly. "This is gonna be fun. I wonder how ordinary humans will use it."

I smirked. "I'm more interested in how someone *other than me* uses it, period. Only myself and my clones have ever worn them."

As I spoke, the suits rapidly disappeared, one at a time. "Donezo!" Harold smiled as he stuck an imaginative pipe in his mouth. "Now all we kin' do is jes' wait 'n see what happens."

"You got that straight."

Part 259a:

"These are the candidates, then?" The man known as Judicator glanced back and forth at my comrades and I from inside his pure white suit. I never really understood why he wore that suit, if all he wanted to do was protect his identity. Something less flashy would have done the trick, if you had asked me.

But now I understood. Nineteen suits identical to his, but painted grey, were set neatly on a long table behind him. Our platoon commander had been in a bit of a rush, but he got the gist of it across. These were super-suits, designed to make a man damn near unkillable. They had all sorts of special abilities we didn't have time to test out, but we'd get time after we killed these invaders. For now, they were made to allow us to wade into the field of battle and not get hurt, leading our forces to victory.

"Yes sir, Judicator. Let's skip the formalities, these boys and girls are my best, I trust all of them with my own life." Commander Hudson nodded briskly at the man who was blessing us with such a divine gift, as she showed no expression on her face. She was a feared and respected woman, one who demanded no special treatment in the military and beat the boys at their own games. We in return would readily lay down our own lives for her, just as she would for us. It was a bond of trust, not ever to be broken, even if it meant death.

"Great. We don't have time to waste." Judicator's mouth-covering thing closed and I felt slightly apprehensive. Then something odd happened... the suits started changing sizes, as if custom altering their own sizes. I ain't never seen such a thing in my life, and I thought it was quite the marvel if I don't say so myself.

Then, all of a sudden, one of the suits vanished and Thompson yelped, all of us jerking our heads over to look at him. He was wearing the suit! It had up and jumped off the desk before we knew it! I didn't even see it move!

Then Sally jerked back, as she was suddenly wearing a suit too! Then Ryan, and after that was Tom! And since I was next- oh *DAMN!* In the blink of an eye, I was suddenly wearing the suit too. I almost wouldn't have noticed it, but my vision suddenly went weird, as if someone had put a pair of weird 3D virtual reality glasses on my face. I appeared to be looking through some video game lens, as I could see all sorts of numbers and readouts. One of them displayed my name, Private Ben L. Brown. A quick readout of my military history scrolled down rapidly. It even knew how many Volgrim I'd killed! Wow!

After a minute, everyone was inside their suits and looking around in awe just like I was, as their suits were scanning the environment and displaying tactical data about all sorts of things, including the terrain.

"Alright, no time to lollygag. I had to leave the frontlines to come here and get you guys suited up. As we speak, your friends are *dying* out there. Let's go over the basics, and quickly. Your suit will make you unbelievably strong, very fast, and will compensate automatically for wasted movements, allowing you to fight far more efficiently. It auto-tracks and aims at enemies, it's essentially impervious to all forms of damage, and once you learn how to use it, you can even use it to fly."

"You can fly in these?!" Sally seemed to fill with glee at the thought. I couldn't blame her, the thought excited me too.

"Yes. Worry about that later though. You can play around with them later, they will be permanent tools for each of you. You need to get out there and fight, right now." Commander Hudson sternly stared to us, as our suit's picked up a large explosion a few miles away.

"Sir, yes sir!" We all quickly switched back to full military mode as we stood at attention and saluted.

"Now get out there and fight, for the people of Britannia! They're counting on you!"

* * *

Each of us went to our own 'sector'. We were strong enough that we didn't need backup, so our orders were to go into enemy territory solo and cut a path for the rest of the troops to swarm in. I don't know how he did it, but Judicator somehow instantly moved me from my spot at base over 13 miles into a different spot in Beijing. The metropolis itself was swarming with Volgrim parasitic scum, and I held nothing but hatred for them. I lost a lot of friends to their murderous ways, and I will never forgive them.

As I appear, my suit starts talking in a strange voice, kinda reminds me of a robotic Jean Claude Van Damme, a favorite classic movie star of mine.

"OPERATOR BROWN, I HAVE DETECTED THREE THOUSAND TWO HUNDRED AND FOURTEEN HOSTILES IN THE IMMEDIATE HALF-MILE VICINITY. WOULD YOU LIKE FOR ME TO SET PRIORITIES FOR TARGETS BASED ON RELATIVE COMBAT ABILITIES AND SPIRITUAL ENERGY THEY ARE LIKELY TO POSSESS, OR BASED ON DANGER TO CIVILIAN LIFE?"

What the hell was he talking about? Spiritual energy? "Uhh, let's focus on the civilians."

"AFFIRMATIVE. PRIORITIZING DANGERS TO CIVILIAN LIFE. FIRST PRIORITY FOUND. CIVILIANS IN DANGER AT THE SUBWAY SYSTEM ENTRANCE LOCATED ON YOUR MAP. THERE ARE SEVEN HUMANS IN DANGER, AND ONE OF THEM IS A HIGH LEVEL DIPLOMAT FOR THE CHINESE EMBASSY. THE OTHERS ARE ALSO MID-LEVEL POLITICIANS AND BUREAUCRATS IN DANGER OF IMMEDIATE DEATH."

I nodded quickly as the location showed up on my HUD, with an arrow telling me which direction to go to. "Alright, let's do it." As I started moving, a thought crossed my mind. In a city of over twenty-five million, I was about to try saving just seven people? Was it because they were 'important' people? Did the computer prioritize something like an individual's value to society over raw numbers of people? In either case, I'm a soldier, and I follow orders. I'll do as I'm told.

I grimaced as I ran. It was tough to see, even with the suit's obviously enhanced visual capabilities, due to the horrendous smog, as well as the smoke that was in the air from fires caused by the Volgrim. Beijing had only gotten worse over the decades, and now you could hardly see twenty feet in front of yourself, maybe a hundred with a super-suit like mine, but that was pushing it.

"Fuck, I can't see a thing." I felt nervous as I ran forwards and muttered to myself. Apparently, the AI decided to respond.

"VISION DEEMED INSUFFICIENT. WOULD YOU LIKE TO SWITCH TO INFRARED MODE?"

"Yes! Yes, that sounds fantastic, err... what was your name again?"

"CONFIRMED. SWITCHING TO INFRARED MODE. OPERATOR BROWN, MY DESIGNATION IS CENTURION."

"Thank you, Centurion." Immediately as I spoke, my vision altered and the world turned into varying shades of red, yellow, orange, grey, and black, as the hotspots lit up all around me. Suddenly my nerves were on fire as I saw absolute chaos unfolding. In a similar manner to how I might have imaged totalitarian extermination of lives in the middle of the 20th century, civilians were being gunned down all over the place. I was watching a vicious slaughter take place, as Volgrim in all directions were tearing into innocent humans and ripping their bodies to pieces, whether with blaster fire, or with terrifying melee weapons.

I stared in horror. I was prioritizing seven humans over all these other people? How could the computer coldly calculate those specific people, even as I watched a dozen people cowering behind some furniture get blown to pieces by an explosive device?

"Centurion, is there some way I can attract the attention of as many Volgrim around me as possible? I need to save the lives of as many people as possible."

"QUERY RECEIVED. THE HIGH PROFILE ASSETS ARE TOP PRIORITY. HEAD TO THE SUBWAY IMMEDIATELY. A DISPLAY THAT DRAWS ATTENTION WILL NOT SAVE THEIR LIVES, AND IS MATHEMATICALLY INSIGNIFICANT."

"What? There are so many other people to save! Is there a way to save all of them?"

"QUERY RECEIVED. AFFIRMATIVE. THERE IS A WAY TO DRAW THE ATTENTION OF A LARGE NUMBER OF HOSTILES. HOWEVER, THE LIVES OF THE ASSETS IN THE SUBWAY ARE DEEMED MORE IMPORTANT TO THE SURVIVAL OF THE HUMAN RACE THAN THE OTHER ONES. PROCEED TOWARDS THE SUBWAY AT ONCE. THEY ARE IN IMMEDIATE DANGER."

I gritted my teeth. "Centurion, I want you to prioritize the lives of as many assets numerically as possible, not based on their perceived value towards human life or whatever else. Do I make myself clear?"

I stared carefully into the sensor array as the AI paused for several painful seconds before responding.

"...CONFIRMED. SWITCHING PRIORITIES TO SAVING HUMAN LIVES BY RAW NUMERICAL VALUE RATHER THAN BY ORDER OF IMPORTANCE. I HAVE SENT A FULL AND DETAILED REPORT TO YOUR SUPERVISOR. WHAT ARE YOUR NEXT ORDERS?"

I openly gaped at the display in front of me, but swallowed my anger and let it steep. So be it, I'd rather face a court martial than let people die. "Create a distraction, let's kill some Volgrim."

Part 260a:

"ANALYZING GENETIC MAKEUP OF PILOT BROWN. ANALYZING COMPLETE. IN ORDER TO FACILITATE HIGHER COMBAT EFFICIENCY, A DIRECT NEURAL LINK IS RECOMMENDED DUE TO YOUR PRIOR MILITARY ENHANCEMENT PROCEDURES. WOULD YOU LIKE TO APPLY THE LINK NOW?"

Ah, excellent. I didn't know this suit could do that. Nowadays, most people were linked up to their tech, even their datapads and holo-watches, so that was an obvious choice. "How much will this increase combat efficiency?"

"PRELIMINARY SCANS INDICATE A ONE HUNDRED TWENTY PERCENT INCREASE IN COMBAT EFFECTIVENESS, SEVENTY PERCENT SPEED INCREASE, AND A FOUR HUNDRED PERCENT MENTAL ACUITY INCREASE. WOULD YOU LIKE TO APPLY THE LINK NOW?"

Jesus, 400%?! That's insane! "Yes! Apply the link."

A split second after I said it, I felt something stab into my spinal dataport as the suit synced up to my brain in an instant. Suddenly, I no longer saw the HUD in my helmet, as I was able to somehow perceive a 360 degree view of the world around myself, as if my entire body was covered in eyeballs. It was weird, in a way, almost as if I were detached from my body. The process was totally painless and took less than a few seconds to complete.

"SYNCHRONIZATION COMPLETE. ADJUSTING TO THE PILOT'S BIO-ENERGY LEVELS. ACTIVATING THE DIVERSION TO DRAW ENEMIES IN. PREPARE FOR COMBAT, PILOT BROWN."

The suit suddenly blasted an ultra high-pitched *whoop* sound that repeated once every two seconds. Imperceptible to the human ear, it was easily detected by the aliens, who cocked their heads up as they detected the strange sound. To them, it almost had a terrifying quality to it, as it sounded like a fellow Volgarian screaming for help while being brutally attacked. With terror in their hearts, they immediately burst out of windows and charged down the streets as they raced towards the sound's source.

I felt my pulse quickening as my enhanced abilities showed over two thousand hostiles converging on my location. Damn, I didn't want this many at once, but if this suit is as good as they say, I should be able to handle it.

I instantly detected the first one as he charged in range of my plasma rifle. Leveling it at him, I instantly realized he wasn't a normal Volgarian, he was one of the *reds*. Firing without

hesitation, I blasted three rapid-fire shots at him, my enhanced target tracking and hyper-fast mental acuity allowing me to trace his movement patterns and fire at his next position before he even knew where he would want to move to.

Before he knew what hit him, he suddenly felt the life vanish from his eyes, as his abominable corpse flopped lifelessly to the ground a few dozen feet away. None of the other soldiers knew why, but the aliens seemed to branch into two distinct species; the greys, and the reds. The greys tended to wear armor and shoot with guns. The reds were more like weird animals, their bodies often having long sword-like arms, and they preferred to fight at melee range. They often tore men apart while shrugging off dozens of bullets. I was lucky because my suit allowed me to hit their vital areas with uncanny precision. I felt like a special ops soldier and I didn't even undergo the higher levels of training.

As I pondered this, more arrived. A mixture of reds and greys. Since reds were harder to kill, I mentally prioritized them first. Firing in bursts of three, I consistently planted my shots in their vital areas, killing off each red within two seconds.

"MULTIPLE LOW LEVEL DEMONS KILLED. ALERT! VOLGRIM ARE PREPARING TO FIRE MICRO-GAUSS CANNON! SWITCHING TO MELEE COMBAT AND HIGH-DENSITY SHIELD MODE."

As a thin film of blue shielding was created over my body and I felt my movement slow noticeably, one thought entered my mind. *Demons? Did Centurion really say Demons?*

I didn't have time to think about it, as a titanic gun fired from down the street a quarter mile away, the shot smashing into me with incredible power. A large projectile, fired at some multiple of the speed of sound slammed into me, my entire visual system lighting up with alerts as I was sent flying into a nearby skyscraper, embedding myself deep into a thick brick wall.

"REPORT: DAMAGE INSIGNIFICANT. SUIT CONFIRMED AT 100% INTEGRITY. PROCEED TO ELIMINATE MICRO-GAUSS CANNON BEFORE IT CAN BE USED AGAINST ALLIED FORCES."

As Centurion told me this, I realized that in fact he was correct. I felt absolutely fine. I hadn't even really felt the impact of the bullet, or being slammed into this wall. For sure, that cannon could level an entire city, and yet it hadn't dealt the slightest damage to me? This suit is the stuff of legends!

Leaping out of the wall with unstoppable force, I tossed my gun aside, as I realized I didn't need it. Racing towards a group of Volgrim firing at me, I spoke quickly. "Switch focus to offense, Centurion."

"AFFIRMATIVE, DEACTIVATING HIGH-DENSITY SHIELD MODE. WOULD YOU LIKE TO ENABLE LIGHTNING MODE?"

Lightning mode?! Holy shit, that sounds awesome! "Yes!! Activate Lightning Mode!"

In the blink of an eye as my shield disappeared, I suddenly realized that my body had somehow become... invisible?! Two reds were looking around in confusion as I raced past them. I jerked my hand out and tore off the head of one with little effort, his disgusting body possessing two long swords for arms, while the other was a large hulking creature, apparently made for heavy labor or rough physical combat. I'd have to get him later.

Running forwards, I took out a group of seven Volgrim, as a strange radar system had begun alerting me to where enemies were clustered.

"ALERT. MICRO-GAUSS CANON HAS RELOADED AND IS CHARGING, IT WILL FIRE IN SEVEN SECONDS."

That's four seconds too long, chumps. You can't hit what you can't see, and you can't fire from what isn't in one piece anymore. Leaping up at a nearby building's wall, I tracked onto the cannon, located in the middle of the street a mere thousand feet away. Piece of cake. Shoving away from the wall with my enhanced leg augments, I screamed towards it at 500 feet per second. After two seconds, I had smashed through it with such explosive speed that it didn't register the hit until I impacted the ground behind it.

Checkmate.

As it exploded, I grabbed a rock nearby and hurled it with pinpoint accuracy towards the head of a Volgrim soldier, his various cerebral parts exploding outwards in various directions as the cannon and his head fell to pieces in the same number of seconds.

This suit... it will change *everything*.

* * *

Founder Dosena watched quietly as the action happened on the screen. Founder Unarin, the eldest of the five Founders, flinched as a specially created Gauss Cannon was destroyed in an instant. "Fascinating. So these are the primitives who humiliated you so effectively, then? It's one thing to hear about it, another to witness it in real time." He shifted his weight as he stood some feet away from the council room's primary viewscreen, even as the other four sat at the long table in their usual designated positions.

Dosena stared at the floor as no reply was able to form on her lips. Founder Cuanali, the fourth, was ready to take the opening. "I believe there has been, a, ah, a mistake, as it were. If

your hypothesis, Unarin, about these 'humans' is ah, correct... then, being descended from Volgrim genes, perhaps they are actually much, ah, smarter, than we gave them credit for?"

Unarin glanced at Cuanali and then back to the viewscreen. "Yes, perhaps. Maybe, instead of thinking of them as primitives, we should think of them as... a parallel species of Volgrim... their brains evolved over tens of thousands, if not millions of rotations, to function differently from our own. As for these genetically altered super soldiers they seem to have deployed, they appear to bend even the laws of physics. Perhaps, in their altered minds, they have discovered branches of science we know nothing of."

Cinculu, the fifth, spoke up quickly. "Cheh... a laughable claim... perhaps they are receiving aid from the other Earth faction the demons spoke of... what were they called again?"

"Angels... they, um, they were the white clothed ones, with the ah, the wings." Cuanali retreated back into her datapad as she poked at numbers and graphs displaying the death counts for all the sides, as transmitted by UMI, the super-computer that had taken up residence in an isolated mainframe where it could harm nothing important, yet still prove its usefulness.

Dosena, finally finding her tongue, quietly whispered. "...I believe we have.... made a mistake..."

"Hmm? What was that, dear sister? Something on your mind? Something you'd like to *share* with the rest of us?" Trayza, the third, glared at Dosena. Among the Founders, Trayza was considered the worst at concealing her emotions, and she often showed flashy displays of disgust and other such primitive functions that served no purpose in an elevated society. Oftentimes her emotions seemed to border on being so excessive that even a primitive species like the humans could not compare.

"You didn't fight them, head on. You don't understand what they're capable of..." Dosena spoke up with more clarity, but in her eyes, a broken soul now lived. "I've fought in thousands of battles during the Great Wars. I've never lost. Those primitives never gave up, and outmaneuvered me *twice* in a row. I cannot say it was just the work of one lone great commander either, they seem to fight in unison, as if there are unseen cues that guide their weapons. To say nothing of their creativity and ingenuity on the battlefield... These are not flukes, they are simply better than we are when it comes to the matters of war."

"Well, um, might that have something to, ah, do with the fact that, ah, we haven't fought in a war... for tens of thousands of rotations?" Cuanali perked back up at the talk of war. While being one of the more reserved members among the Founders, she actually loved playing war simulations when there were no official duties to attend to. She might secretly even be considered one of the more war-loving members among the council.

"Yeah, we grew soft. Maybe we deserve to lose some battles, and if we lose a few trillion of our troops, that can only be good considering the pending crisis..." Trayza grimaced as she and everyone else among the Founders remembered what she referred to.

"How many more orbital cycles do we have?" Unarin turned away from the battle occurring on the viewscreen, as a grey-suited lone human wiped out an entire platoon of Volgarian and Demon troops. Looking out the plexiglass window, he stared up at their sun, which had dimmed another two percent this orbital cycle.

"If we're lucky, maybe five hundred more orbits." Trayza practically spit the words out as she rolled her eyes dramatically.

Cuanali changed the viewscreen from the battle to a series of diagrams and projections of their star's remaining lifespan. Cinculu read the reports from his dossier as the animations played. "Let's see, Refuge was finished five orbital cycles ago, and is now home to one hundred billion of our most elite citizens, with room for a billion more via the special lottery system... but we lack enough metallic ores or pseudo-metal to attempt to build another Refuge, so... for now, it is likely that 99.992% of our people will die if we can find no long term solution."

"And the other projects?"

"We have found four potential planets, including the habitable planet Earth, but two of those planets are in the Sol system, and the humans occupy both of them. The other two planets exceed twenty-thousand lightyears in distance from Volgarius. As long of a trip as Earth is, those planets are forty-percent further away."

"Surely some are closer and we might try Volforming them? Five hundred orbital cycles might be long enough." Unarin felt hope creep into his voice as he turned and faced Cinculu.

"No. The closest Volformable planet is 5,000 lightyears away. The materials needed would take at least two thousand trips, using our entire fleet and a potential 100% max efficiency response time. In a time of war such as this, we would be lucky to scrape together a quarter of the fleet at 10% efficiency. It's a dream that will never produce anything of value."

Despair clouded Unarin's face as he paced back over to the Plexiglass window that oversaw the capital of Volgarius. Over a trillion Volgarians lived in this mighty stronghold, and nearly every one of them was going to die unless he could solve this crisis. "Curses. Is there nothing we can do?"

Dosena spoke up hesitantly. "The Devil that gave us aid, the one who calls himself Satan... perhaps he could be of use. Think of the fortress and the dimensional pathway he created for us. Clearly he possesses a science that might aid us, the one that bends the very fabric of reality as we know it. Perhaps he can give us an insight that will save our people?"

Unarin nodded slowly. "Yes, perhaps... very well, call for him. I would do anything if it saved just one more percent of our species. *Anything.*"

Founder Dosena reached into the folds of her garments, as she pulled out a familiar purple crystal she had grown all too used to calling upon over the last few orbits. What unfair offer would he demand in return for his services *this* time? She remembered how he coldly told them the cost for a rift gate would be ten billion Volgarian lives. It had caused the First no end of anguish to accept such an offer. And this time? Perhaps he would demand a trillion.

It would still be worth it, if it saved the rest of their people.

Dosena flinched inwardly as she rubbed the purple crystal, and a familiar glow escaped from its innards.

Part 261a:

I paced the leftover carnage in Beijing, along with Commander Hudson and two of the people who had donned my Hypersuit, as they have now coined it. The city was in decent shape, all things considered, and plenty of buildings were still intact, but the streets were covered in blood, body parts, rubble, and more than a few buildings and skyscrapers had crumbled into dust.

"How many people did we manage to save?" I glanced over at Hudson.

She cringed visibly. "Roughly half of the population survived, but that only means that half of them also died. We're still verifying reports. O'Neill managed to find the portal they were using to arrive here from their world, or wherever else. After securing the location and eliminating all the of the Volgrim, the enemy ended up closing the portal to prevent anyone from re-entering it from our side. All that's left now is a mop-up operation."

"How many are left?" One of the two commandos spoke up.

"A few thousand, Ben. Don't worry about it, we've got the others on it. I only need you here to deliver reports, as well as anything you might have gleaned. After that, we need to go to Paris. There are many cities under attack right now without any Hypersuit Commandos to eliminate those aliens, and both of you will be going solo to a city by yourself."

I glanced over at Ben. Pilot Brown was apparently the highest performing pilot among the commandos in the Beijing sector, also being the only one with a direct neural link to his suit. It wasn't something I had ever tried, but I was debating my choice now. His kill count was almost ten times higher than everyone else, and according to the stats Harold was receiving on each HC's combat efficiency, Ben also had a 98.5% accuracy rating with ranged weapons, exceeding the average of 80% from his fellow HC's by a large margin. Naturally Centurion often force-aimed your shots so that they would hit the enemy more often, but he worked totally in tandem with Centurion. The only shots he missed were ones that were blocked by especially elite enemies, and his melee combat skills were used once that happened. He was quite the elite soldier, if I didn't say so myself.

Ben and Sally's helmets opened up entirely, exposing their face. I don't know what expression I expected on Ben's face, but he seemed... *happy*? He wasn't smiling, but there wasn't a trace of anxiety to be seen. Perhaps, like myself many years ago, he was enjoying his new superhuman abilities, and was experiencing an endorphin rush.

"Well, Commander, it's about what was already reported. Three greys to every red. The reds are definitely tougher than the greys, I had to go into melee nearly every single time. Actually, I probably used melee more often than ranged, due to how effective this suit is. Centurion reported that after all the damage I took, my suit was still at 99.7% integrity."

Hudson raised her hand. "Uh, Centurion? Who is that?"

"Right, sorry. It's the Hypersuit's AI program. He's quite efficient." Ben smiled slightly but then quickly stifled it. He really *did* seem to have enjoyed himself. I can understand the feeling.

"Ben Brown, you did a good job out there, as did you, Sally Weiss." I paused for a second as I absorbed what he had just said. "Ah, also... reds? Greys? What were you referring to just now?"

Sally shrugged. "Well, see, it's the Volgrim. They seem to be divided into two types, or species, or whatever. They're aliens, so I guess weirdness is to be expected. Anyway, the greys use a lot of technology, and the reds are like weird mutated monsters or something, they tend to be melee or use some weird inner energy to fight with. I don't really get it myself. You don't know about them?" Sally raised an eyebrow as she stared at me.

Ben scratched his cheek as he kicked a rock to the side. "You know, that's the thing. I was in the middle of combat.... and maybe I misheard or something, but I could swear Centurion said something about 'demons'. Actually, he said it a couple different times. Is that going to be an unofficial classification for them or something?"

I felt my heart pound in my chest. I knew this was going to happen. It would first start like this, with rumors, unsubstantiated but gripping nonetheless. I didn't expect people to not initially make the connection that these might be demons, but this could perhaps work out in the end. After this, what happens? Probably best to control the message now before it gets out of hand.

Before I could respond, Hudson spoke up. "Demons, huh? I don't see why not. 'Greys' and 'reds' seems like an imprecise classification. We'll just use Volgrim and Demonic Variant as the unofficial classification for now. Some people might NOT like the allusion to their skin color anyway, Ben. I'm sure you understand."

Sally glanced away towards a bunch of corpses in the distance. One of them happened to be a demon, and as she eyeballed it, she nodded. "Yeah, I see the resemblance. They really do look like demons... creepy. They've even got the horns."

I felt my anxiety sink into my stomach as I flicked my eyes from person to person. There's really no point hiding it anymore... I suppose. But then again, if we were to acknowledge the presence of demons, we'd have to accept that angels are real too. If we bring angels and gods into this war... will the future repeat itself? Will they all be slaughtered?

I don't know if I want the answer to that question.

Hudson dismisses the two Hypersuit Commandos and I mentally tell Harold to send the both of them to wherever they're needed. Fifty-five cities are under attack worldwide, and more are sure to come. We can't be focusing just on those that have higher importance monetarily or professionally.

"Judicator, an extremely important man was killed today. I have a report here... it's from Ben Brown's AI." Hudson holds up her datapad and shows me. Wu Tao Chaohong, an ambassador visiting from Shanghai...

"Ben let him die?"

"Yes. Ben apparently didn't want to save only a small number of lives of 'elites'. But in doing so, this man died. He wasn't just anybody, he was negotiating an important deal with the Japanese. He had established a lot of trust with their current prime minister and was working on procuring a... top secret substance." Hudson's stern gaze flicked away for a second before returning. "Well, you know how 'top secret' government doings work, I would presume. In any case, his negligence led to this man being brutally murdered. Ben was able to save tens of thousands of Chinese people but..."

As she paused, I butted in. "But what? He saved the lives of a lot of people. Maybe it was the wrong decision, but are you saying you think that man was more important than all of them?"

"Perhaps." Hudson snapped back almost reflexively. "Most would say Einstein is more important than ten thousand, even a million average Americans back in his day. If those people all die later because the project Chaohong was working on fails, then not only were their lives saved in vain, we lost our chance at winning the war."

"I think you might be acting a tad melodramatic. Doubtless, that ambassador was an important man, but wars aren't won by a single man, they're a combined effort from all of us."

"In some ways, yes. But I disagree. Especially coming from *you*, Judicator." Hudson narrowed her eyes and smiled ever so slightly as she rubbed her fine royal purple military garments. "Were it not for just you, humanity might have been exterminated on three different occasions. We would never have beaten these aliens."

"I don't know about that, commander. Sometimes I wonder if I wasn't the cause of this whole war in the first place. Maybe my time travel is the direct reason they saw humanity as a threat. If that were the case, I would go from being an asset to a liability, wouldn't you agree?"

She smiled more broadly. "Perhaps. I'll have to speak to Ben about this later, but my point still stands. In any case, those Hypersuits will be quite invaluable in the war effort. I hope you...

produce more of them."

"Don't worry, I will." I wanted to hesitate and say no, but frankly a thousand Hypersuits wouldn't be enough to win the war. They certainly help to level the playing field though, and that's the best I could hope for. "Keep fighting the good fight, commander. I'm returning to base."

"Excellent. Hope to see more from you, Judicator. You keep us motivated here on the ground."

Part 262a:

First Founder Unarin stared at the demon, no expression visible on his face. Despite this, Dosena could detect anger bubbling beneath the surface with her enhanced psionic abilities. "*Absolutely not.* I cannot agree to that."

Satan sighed as he shrugged his shoulders heavily. "Well, I am simply giving you the offer, Founder Unarin. You may accept or ignore it. But you cannot deny the usefulness, can you? And really, saving the lives of 90% of your people, that must be quite a noble goal to work towards."

"But... a trillion dead... that would be..." Unarin's face was pale as he thought of the consequences. "There is a large difference between being unable to save fourteen trillion lives, and deliberately exterminating one trillion to save thirteen trillion. How do I even choose..."

Satan rolled his eyes. "I don't know, that much is up to you. It took us thousands of years to create our own dimensional space to live in, and the living conditions are hardly ideal. We were only able to do it thanks to our innate connection with thought energy. The only other way to do it is with a mass sacrificial ritual." *Well, perhaps not the only way...* Satan thought to himself about the human who could wordsmith. That one might be able to find another way, but it would be a bad idea to bring his ability up at a time like this.

Cinculu, the fifth Founder, glared at the demon. "You ask too much, devil. If push comes to shove, we may have to consider this but... unlike in your society or that of the humans, we have no 'dregs' to choose from. All Volgrim contribute to the greater good, all have purpose. To kill a tenth of our people would be to cut off an arm. It would be possible, but far from ideal."

Satan turned his back to the table and leaned his rear against it as he rubbed his right arm's muscles with his left. "As I said before, it's just an option. No need to get so angry." He paused for a moment dramatically as he turned and gazed out the plexiglass window towards the sprawling metropolis outside. "Well, actually, I suppose there is *another* option, but you probably won't like it either."

"Another option? What is it? What are you talking about?" Dosena spoke up as she eyed the demon with suspicion. None at the table truly trusted him, since all of his 'deals' had awful conditions, but right now he was perhaps their only hope for resolving their world's crisis.

"As you all know, there is a faction on my planet called the 'angels', along with their rulers, the 'gods'. Well, they just so happen to possess their very own dimensional space, which they call 'heaven'. If we were to drag them into the war, you would not only be able to eliminate an important, powerful enemy faction on Earth, you would be able to claim their dimensional

space for yourself. At the least, it would be big enough to give a trillion or so of your people housing, and with the proper adjustments, you might even manage to increase its dimensional space further for all of them as a whole."

Unarin rotated his finger in the air slowly as he thought about it. "I see. This suggestion of yours would actually seem to be far easier and with less negative consequences than sacrificing a trillion of my people to create our own space. Why didn't you suggest it first?"

"Ah well, that would be due to time constraints. Pacifying the humans to take over their planet for yourself will be difficult, and Earth won't be able to house more than a trillion Volgrim at its maximum, but in order to take over Heaven, you'll need to pacify Earth and Heaven simultaneously. A tall order, to be sure."

Cinculu eyeballed Satan curiously. "Alright, I'll personally consider this. What do you have to gain if we eliminate the angels and gods? You wouldn't suggest something unless there was something in it for yourself."

Satan grinned evilly as he returned Cinculu's gaze. "How correct you are. For me, I will finally gain my revenge. That's all. If you kill the angels and the gods, I will have finally completed my longest, hardest fought goal. I live only to see this happen."

Unarin nodded as he waved his hand at the devil. "Very well then. Begone, please. I will discuss your proposal at length with my family. We will give you a response... soon."

"Excellent. I can't wait for your reply." Satan snickered quietly under his breath as he made a few motions with his hand, vanishing into the void to return to his own people.

Part 263a:

"I don't trust them either." Diablo stood alongside Satan, with Agares, Belial, Bael, and Beleth all lazing about in various spots at a rather large and luxurious spa. "The Volgrim seem too familiar to me. I don't like their smell."

Satan's face held an expression of pondering, as he thought about the last few years and the demons' contact with the Volgrim. Nodding slightly, he made a reply. "The Volgrim are like the humans, in more ways than one. In fact, they only hold two key differences, which would be their terrible mouths filled with dozens of razor sharp teeth, and their strange personalities. Some Volgrim are completely mute when it comes to expressing emotions, others are borderline neurotic. Very... touchy."

Beleth shrugged as she sat at a table nearby the spa, a long smattering of papers spread out before her, with Agares sitting directly across from her. "Really, the teeth are the only major difference. Plenty of humans have personality traits that could be likened to the Volgrim. Even their height, body build, and the color they bleed are similar. They're eerily similar, if you ask me."

"Satan, what have you been able to glean of their race's history from your conversations with them?" Agares shifted his glasses on his nose as he continued to read a digital newspaper report about the ongoing Volgrim carnage, the paper being written in Chinese from one of China's top news companies. "I'm interested to learn more about their kind."

Satan tapped his chin thoughtfully. "Well, thanks to an ability I took from a certain goddess during the First War, I have some ability to read minds at a surface level. Their words told me little, but one of the Founders was a quiet one, the fourth, as I recall. She didn't speak much, but she thought about many different things. She actually had this interesting theory... rather silly, if you ask me... but her theory was that humans are actually an ancient Volgrim colony of some sort. Possibly millions of years old."

Agares shifted his gaze from his nifty electronic reader over to meet Satan's gaze. "Really? That theory is..." He paused for a few long moments as he lingered on his thoughts, then he spoke up again. "Satan, would you be so kind as to humor an old man? I have a theory of my own I should like to float."

Satan smiled kindly at his elder as he turned and walked over to the table where he was seated. Standing tall before it, he nodded quietly. "Certainly. As the oldest of our kind, your wisdom is always useful on any occasion."

Agares coughed quietly as he scratched his long, greying beard. "Well, as everyone knows, I am not the first demon ever birthed, that would be the ancient one named Grimoire. However, she, as well as all of the eldest demons, died long ago during the first Purge. I was the only one who survived."

Satan pulled out a seat and eased into it, as Diablo looked on with interest from his own seated position on a nearby towel. "Yes, you've mentioned this before. It was sheer luck that you had not died."

"Well... there is more to it than that. Do you know the origin of the demons?" Agares cocked an eye as he reached over and took a sip of wine.

"Well, now that you mention it, I do not. What of it?"

Agares swallowed several sips of wine before gently placing the delicate glass back on the table. "Well, see, demons are not evolved from lower life forms. We were created, actually. By the angels and gods, or more specifically, by the original Titans."

Belial glanced over from her resting spot inside the bubbling heated spa. "Oh? I did not know of this."

"I am the only one who knows, truth be told. I never brought it up, because there wasn't much to gain from it. It changes nothing with regards to why we hate the angels, and if anything, it would only increase our hatred for them even more." Agares gave a slight wave of his hand as he spoke, as if to brush off never mentioning this crucial fact about their legacies. "Actually, Grimoire told me of this, a few hundred years before she was killed. You see, in the beginning, demons were created as powerful, majestic red-skinned servants for the Titans. We were created essentially as lapdogs, to serve them hand and foot, or to... pleasure them. You know how it goes."

The others nodded thoughtfully. Given how the depravity of the Titans was often spoken of, it was obvious they would gravitate towards such unethical behavior.

"To make a long story infinitely shorter, some demons began to foment a rebellion. They possessed keen IQ's and an understanding of thought energy and how it worked. Before they could fully rise up though, the Titans learned of their treachery and killed many of them off. Some, like me, escaped. The titans learned from their mistake, and when they next created demons, they created the imps. Stupid, idiot little creatures that were far too weak to fight back. While we lost our use for their carnal delights, we still made for useful servants. They continued to hunt all of the remaining old demons, and I only survived by using magic to turn myself into an imp to blend in, though I did lose much of my power in doing so."

"Lucky that you did so." Diablo piped up, nodding with approval. "You are the only one left who could tell us this news. This is useful to know, indeed."

"Yes. Useful..." Agares voice cracked slightly, as he thought of ancient friends he would never again see. "I am... millions of years old. I witnessed the original cataclysm, you know... the one that killed the ancient dragons and changed the face of our world." As Agares spoke of *dragons*, Satan's eyes shifted away for a microsecond, glancing at Belial, just as she glanced at him. He quickly returned his gaze back to Agares, who was so deep in thought he hadn't even noticed, nor had Beleth, her nose still buried in mountains of paperwork.

"Something though, about that first cataclysm... the asteroid that killed the monsters and Titans of old, giving rise to the Gods and Angels of today... it opened the door for so much more, and now I question it. I question if that really was just an ordinary rock that fell from the sky."

Satan's eyes suddenly narrowed. "Wait, the rock from tens of millions of years before? Impossible. If you're implying that belonged to the Volgrim, then why would it wait so long for them to appear as humans?"

Agares shrugged as he hesitantly reached for his final swig of wine, before pausing just as he was about to touch the glass. "I do not know, Satan. We know little of the Volgrim. Perhaps, hundreds of millions of years ago, their technology was in its infancy. Perhaps their species was, as well. Maybe their technology had to wait until an ape happened upon it. Perhaps their technology gave birth to the rise of the mammals. I don't know... I'm just an old man."

Diablo found himself nodding along as he laid back on his towel, resting his head on top of his thick battle-trained arms. "Agares, this information is useful. Even if it were totally incorrect, and it isn't, mind you.... this might help us win the true war. The one we've always fought in our hearts."

"Perhaps the reason the demons were able to break free of the Titans' clutches was because of the humans. They made for competent slaves. Better than us, while lacking in magic power, like our fully realized demonic predecessors were. Yes, the humans that kicked and spat on us, might very well be descended from the group that we are now allied with." Satan snickered as he thought about it. He liked this theory, he liked it *a lot*. "Agares, as always, your wisdom is truly incredible. We're lucky to have you on our side."

Satan didn't speak of Leviathan, but the more he thought about it, the more he realized just how trivial mutation would seem to a beast of his incredible power. Whatever happened to that old dragon? He often wondered about it and sometimes had sleepless nights, but in the last few thousand years, the dragon had never reappeared. Perhaps, in some burst of anger, he had

killed himself, scattering his energy to the void forever. A tragic waste, but to be expected of one who hated imprisonment as much as he.

Satan reached forwards, grabbing the remainder of the bottle of red wine for himself. "Agares, you are the father to all of us. I'm glad to call you a demon."

Part 264a:

January 4th, 2050, my 37th birthday.

Amy waited patiently while her mental communicator slowly pinged her adoptive mother's communicator. This far out near Phobos, it took a while for even lightspeed to make a connection. Once connected though, the revolutionary transdimensional mental-phones would allow for connection anywhere within ten Astronomical Units to only have a delay of about one second between sending and receiving responses. It wasn't instant, but it was pretty close.

Jorge was wandering around in the other room as he prepped himself for the dinner party they would be going to, shortly. How fast ten years of marriage passed... just like that. No kids yet, but these things took time. As the leader of the Galaxy Exploration Force, or the GEF, as they were called, Amy just didn't have the time to have kids and do mom-like stuff. Besides, the innovations in life extensions via nanobots and gene alteration meant they had plenty of time to think about that stuff later.

Her mental communicator finally made the clicking noise that indicated the connection was successful.

"Ah, Amy! Is that you, sweetheart?" Carolyn picked up and upon receiving the mental feedback indicating who was calling, she seemed pleasantly surprised.

"Hi mom, how are you?" As mental images of the two participants slowly began to coalesce in each others minds, Amy noted with alarm that her mother no longer looked as youthful and vibrant as she had a few years before. Her face was quite haggard, and despite the fierce smile she put on, she seemed to be quite melancholy.

"Oh, you know... I've been doing a bit of this, a bit of that. Ever since your father passed..." Carolyn mumbled something else, but Amy didn't catch it.

"Mom... you don't need to keep beating yourself up over that. It wasn't your fault."

"I know, it's just... the signs... they were always there." Carolyn paused for a few moments to take a quick breath before raising her gaze up. "Ah well, can't do anything about it anymore. How are you?"

"I'm good, as usual, I suppose." Amy paused as she thought of what to say. "Oh, right! I forgot to tell you, but the very first interplanetary colonization attempt is going to be made in one week!"

Her mom brightened up noticeably. "Wow, splendid! You and Jorge have been treating that trip like your firstborn child! Is he going to lead it, or are you?"

"He is, but I'll be leading the second one which follows immediately after. We have a real chance, thanks to Judicator, to colonize distant worlds. If he can do what he did here on Mars, but on a different planet, we can start colonizing other solar systems. It's the key to surviving extinction events!"

Amy always got a bit excitable when she started talking about being a colonist, but her mother's eyes glazed over slightly, as she wasn't very much into anything science-y. "That's great, Amy. I'm so glad for you! Your father would be so proud if he could see how well you've grown."

Amy and her mother spoke for a while longer about a great many other things, finally ending the call ten minutes later, just in time for Jorge to finish assembling his decorated military uniform together.

As he walked in the room, he smiled at his beautiful wife, as she also wore her own military uniform, decorated with the White Eagle Crest for her heroism during the first skirmishes with the Volgrim.

The Volgrim... Jorge's smile was slightly stilted as he thought about them. It had been over twenty years since they last attacked humanity from space. Their antics had fallen to little more than minor acts of terrorism, as humanity's population had swelled to nearly twenty billion, taking over many areas of the Moon, as well as Mars and its two moons. There was talk of settling on Venus, and quiet talks among the upper ranks of starting a head-on assault on the Volgrim themselves. Thanks to a sophisticated network of computer engineers, they had long since decoded the location of the Volgrim homeworld, as well as important landmarks and other useful tactical data from ships seized during the first and second major skirmishes with their species.

Jorge sighed, as he walked up behind his wife and started rubbing her shoulders. "Amy, are you ready to see me off? We won't be able to see each other for five years..."

Amy nodded as she leaned back and kissed her husband tenderly. "I love you, Jorge... make sure you return in one piece."

Jorge snickered. "You too. We're both going to become famed galaxy explorers, you know. I can't lose to you, I'll be the one setting all the records."

"Only because you'll have a headstart. If you don't pay attention, I'll overtake you instantly." Amy grinned as she and her husband stepped out the door, the massive mansion closing itself up as their butler A.I. took over, putting the house in hibernation mode.

Part 265a:

Three angels and a god stood in the middle of Central Park, in the finally rebuilt New York City, part of the Third Division of Britannia. Their bodies disguised with advanced magic to resemble the humans they walked amongst, Gabriel, Raphael, Uzziel, and Zeus eyeballed humans as they hovered around on various interesting looking contraptions.

"It's so peaceful down here, on the planet." Zeus mused as he eyeballed a father and his son playing holo-ball with each other in the distance. "You almost wouldn't be able to tell that the humans are causing us no end of grief."

"Five percent." Gabriel followed Zeus' gaze as he spoke. "Five percent of humans are religious now. Mass atheism has reached its peak."

Raphael wagged a finger tellingly. "As I said they would. I warned you... and now drastic measures will have to be taken."

"Yes, yes, we know, Raphael. We're allies, not enemies." Zeus cast a quick glance at the old man who was sitting on a stump not too far away from the memorial of those killed in the Metropolitan Massacre, as humans had come to call it. While the world seemed peaceful now, war was still raging in many places. Rumors swirled of shapeshifters who blended in with human society, and secret underground bases constructed overnight. Even Zeus didn't know if the rumors were true or false, but he suspected their existence was not merely rumor.

"Do we really have any we can call allies?" Uzziel spoke up, her words carrying an aura of doubt. "The humans do not know of our existence, and most of them no longer worship us. The only countries that still pray are those who are continuously ravaged by the Volgrim, the third worlders. The first world countries have all but abandoned religion. Even if they knew of our existence, and even if they knew we required spiritual energy to live, would they give it to us?"

Raphael shook his head slightly. "I believe not. And think of ourselves, for a moment. What have we done to aid the humans? We've been bystanders for decades, while they fought both the Volgrim and the demons. What do we deserve, if not scorn?"

"Forget giving us thought energy to survive, we would be lucky if they didn't come to us and rip us from Heaven." Gabriel scratched his back, wistfully wishing he could feel his wings, though they had been temporarily absorbed into himself to blend in with humans. "I think... we need to reveal ourselves."

Zeus jerked his head towards Gabriel. "I should think not! We have other ways we can solve this problem."

"How?" Gabriel jerked his open palm forwards at Zeus. "No disrespect intended, but we're out of options. We're going to have angels dying in masses, soon. There are nearly 500 billion angels in Heaven. We made the resurrection criteria easier to fall into than the criteria for receiving thought energy even was. In order to receive thought energy, humans have to constantly pray and worship... but to be resurrected, they need only pledge allegiance to a god or an angel, even if just halfheartedly. Then, if they die, they are resurrected. We don't even have criteria for whether a human is good or bad, nor criteria for if they regularly donated thought energy their entire life."

Uzziel nodded at Gabriel, as she then turned to Zeus. "Face it, my lord. We have to do something desperate. Wouldn't it be better for humans to know of our existence, as we send angels down to aid them in the war? Humans might not only become much more prayerful, they might get some joy from seeing long-dead relatives, which would give us goodwill, but if those angels then die in battle, they will at least help in the war against the Volgrim, rather than simply vanishing into the ether when their energy runs out. It's... it's..." Uzziel paused as she struggled to find the words she was looking for.

"...Less wasteful. That's what you mean, eh?" Raphael glanced up at her with a sly grin on his face. "Sometimes, wisdom takes root in a young and fertile mind, even more easily than an old and worn out one. Zeus, you would do well to heed her words."

Zeus grimaced at the thought. "Well... my original thought was that we might simply have to perform a culling... but you bring up good points. I can't see many negatives in this route. Eventually, humans are likely to find files on our kind and learn of our existence. Better to wait for a good moment and strike at the Volgrim, than to rot and die up here uselessly."

Raphael's grin was replaced with a more careful expression as he kneaded his beard with his fingers. "You know, this presents us quite the opportunity, when you think about it. We could craft a narrative, like 'aid from the gods and angels'. When the next major battle occurs, we will have angels rain down from above and smite the enemy, revealing ourselves while also making a spectacle of our appearance."

"Ah! That is a good idea!" Gabriel clapped once enthusiastically as he mulled it over himself. "If humans start to think of us as ordinary, we will become quite boring in their eyes and undeserving of any special praise or prayer... but if we become a holy spectacle, this would restore their faith in us! This could single-handedly restore the faith of millions, even billions of believers!"

"We have to orchestrate it though." Uzziel used her thoughtful and methodical brain to toss a plan together in an instant. "Instead of aiding in one battle, we should send a million angels

down, to all corners of the planet, so news of our appearance cannot be blocked out anywhere. Giving out food to war torn villages, appearing in major cities, and aiding the war effort, all at once! But... then..." Uzziel hesitated as she thought of the next part of the plan. "...After that, we should vanish again."

"What? Vanish? Why?!" Zeus felt his annoyance blow up at the thought of all that work and a big reveal, only to disappear back up into the clouds.

"Well, you see, it has to do with this idea I learned from the, uh... video games..." Uzziel's voice quieted as she realized what she had said.

"...Video games? You mean... you've been interacting socially with that human, haven't you?" Zeus felt the annoyance vanish as a dull expression clouded his eyes. "You shouldn't trust him too much. Jason is a hero, but that doesn't make him a champion of the angels and gods, nor even of the humans. He's as dangerous of an enemy as he is an ally."

Gabriel shrugged slightly. "I trust him, personally. Compared with all the past heroes, his power seems limitless. He still hasn't told me what his abilities are or how they work, but he appears to have many abilities. He's cloned himself, made Mars livable, fought Satan one-on-one and survived..."

Zeus sneered. "Precisely. You don't know what his abilities are! He's the first hero to ever not reveal himself to us immediately, nor to explain in detail how they work. He hasn't even sought training with Raphael to enhance his abilities! He's a fool."

Uzziel rolled her eyes slightly. "I disagree. Listen, about what I was saying... if we reveal ourselves, but stay in the presence of humans for a long period of time, they will grow comfortable with us, and our mystique will vanish. Jason does this himself, only appearing among the humans once in a while, leaving them to fight their major battles."

"He has turned himself into a godlike figure, who only appears when the battle has become impossible to win. He understands that heroes are not the solution, they are simply a tool to improve humanity itself. He explained to me that he learned the idea from horror video games, where you only see monsters for a split second, causing your mind to imagine them as much scarier than they actually are. If we can turn this around and use it ourselves, we can reveal ourselves, lose some of the lesser angels, and bolster our spiritual energy input from the humans!"

Uzziel was talking quickly, and she seemed quite excited by the idea. Zeus didn't seem to buy it, but Gabriel and Raphael had already decided it was worth giving it a shot. Zeus sighed. "Fine, fine. I think if we're going to do this, we need to think of the ramifications more carefully, so I

only say you must draft a full plan within the next year or so. If you do that, I will consider it more carefully."

"Excellent! I can't wait!" Uzziel smiled cheerfully as a human woman and her dog walked past nearby.

Uzziel's smile faded as she watched the humans milling about in the park. "I don't want the humans to be killed off. I have a fondness for their species."

Raphael raised an eyebrow at her words as he watched her staring at the father and his son putting away their holo-projectors. "You don't say..."

Part 266a: Shift

I feel like I've been fighting for a long time now, maybe even half of my life. Well... it's pretty close to that. It's been a long time coming, but I was finally promoted to the head of the Hypersuit Commando Defense Corps. The HCDC has been primarily responsible for beginning all Volgrim defense missions, where we start by eliminating as many as possible before the rest of the troops come in to finish off the remnants.

How many Volgrim have we killed? Official tallies indicate that the HC's have killed over twenty million Volgrim by ourselves, but that's only due to our suits recording each death in its databanks. Their bodies tend to dissolve on death, which Command has told us is to prevent autopsies and other such investigative work into their biology. It doesn't matter though. We know where their homeworld is located. The plans for a full scale invasion are underway.

Soon, we will crush them entirely.

"Chief Officer Brown, I'm from the Vietnam HQ." I turn around to see a man has walked in the room behind me. Since he's wearing a Hypersuit, I'd normally assume he's one of my own, but clearly he's one of Judicator's clones, based on his familiar voice. I'm not wearing a suit right now, and my senses always feel dull, and my normal body weak. It's weird to not instantly understand everything around myself all at once. It's... unsettling.

"Judicator, good to see you. How is the prep going?" I turn around and smile at the suited man behind me. I glance at his right shoulder and note that it has seven blue stripes on it. A seventh generation clone? The original must be desperate for more help.

He returns the grin slightly. "It's going well. We've finally manufactured enough Trifrancium to get the fleet to Volgarius and back, but not enough to call a safe amount. We still need a bit more for a safety zone, and in case of emergencies."

I cock an eyebrow. "I thought you had made a confident prediction last year that you had a special technology that would quickly create lots of Trifrancium once we'd manufactured the first batch?"

His smile faltered. "Ah, yeah. Unfortunately it required too much... energy. The, erm, technology works... but it's so slow that we might as well just manufacture it the normal way. Turns out Earth had many of the deposits we needed, it's just painfully hard to mine and refine the stuff."

I shrug back at him. "Can't be helped, I suppose. If it were that easy to create the stuff, the Volgrim would be launching yearly assaults on Earth."

Judicator itched his chin as he chuckled. "Yeah.. heh, I suppose so." He paused for a second as his head cocked slightly upwards, as if he was thinking about something. "Oh, yes, how much longer until this area's EPS is online? We need to go global before we launch our initial assault on Volgarius."

"Hmm..." I actually wasn't sure, so I turned around and shuffled through some papers on my desk. Mulling my way past the files on the recent destruction of Bolivia, I find the papers regarding what I was looking for. Skimming through them, I turn back to Judicator. "Apparently by the end of the month ours will be online. The LPS is already a go."

Of course, we were referring to the Earth Protective Shield and the Local Protective Shields, which would create a high-density energy barrier around the planet to protect us from orbital bombardments, meteorites, and other such space-based offensives. They weren't strong enough to protect us from a massive enemy battlecruiser self destructing itself downwards into a major metropolitan area, but if the enemy were that suicidal, not much *could* protect us from that sort of kamikaze-style attack.

"You're doing good work, Ben. We're doing alright without you on the frontlines, but we do miss your spirit and abilities in the art of combat." Judicator gave me a quick thumbs up. In private, both he and his clones weren't very stuffy or bureaucratic, they tended towards lighthearted banter, but I had noticed a shift as the years wore on. Combat and killing can change a man, dramatically.

"I hate paperwork." I shifted my glance back towards the tables behind me, then back to him. "But you know how it is, I'm just too old to be fighting out there. Have to leave it behind to the youngsters. They need me here."

A big shit-eating grin spread across Judicator's face. "Ha! You're such a liar! You haven't aged a day, nanobots can make you practically immortal, you know. Hell, you're probably twice as fast, twice as sharp, and twice as keen with that Hypersuit as when you started fighting all those years ago."

I had been smiling along with him, but when he mentioned nanobots, I felt an odd feeling wash through my body. Almost like... regret? As my smile faded I walked around behind my desk and slumped in my chair. Judicator walked over and flopped down across from me, taking my hint.

"Do you ever wonder though... if we're doing the right thing? Aren't we becoming less human all the time?"

Judicator shrugged slightly. "I'm from the future, but I don't know many details. We could lose to the Volgrim still. The only way to know for sure that we have changed the future is if

Earth survives past the year 2399. That's all."

I shake my head slowly. "That's not what I'm talking about. Remember when nanobots were becoming common, back in 2027, and we had that massive hacking incident? Humans started crazily attacking and killing one another. We did that because of the robots inside our bodies. Twenty-three years later, we're even more machine now than we were then. We can remotely disable pain if we need to. Our bodies can slowly regrow limbs without the need for a doctor. People run faster for ten times longer than the greatest Olympic athlete could at the turn of the century."

Judicator interrupted me. "Yes, but those are all good things. The nanobot incident was one terrible tragedy, but we fixed it, and the incidents since then have equaled zero. Humanity stumbles, and then it finds its way. I have faith in my fellow humans."

"That's not my point." I looked at him carefully. It was hard to see his expression when we spoke, but his lower face and voice could still change, putting his emotions on full display. "Scientists today say that 27% of all children will be biologically engineered or otherwise altered while still in the womb, and 5% of all births will happen inside the birthing pods instead of inside a woman. We no longer have fistfights over disagreements, we solve our problems in simulated holographic arenas, which separates our physical pain from learning lessons. Schools are being replaced by caregiving androids at alarming rates. 78% of humans in the developed world have been altered by nanobots or robots in some way, and even 22% of people in third world countries have been altered. By the end of this century, nearly every human is likely to be mechanical in some small way."

Judicator waved his hand at me dismissively. "That probably does sound awful to *you*, but we also used to die of Malaria and Smallpox, until scientists invented vaccines. Progress means change. It sounds like you just *fear* change. I bet a lot of people love being able to enhance their bodies and live more fulfilling lives as a result."

"Vaccines aren't the same thing. A vaccine eliminates the virus, but the human returns to their normal state afterwards. It doesn't alter anything fundamental about a person. Augmentations do. Technology as a whole does. We're becoming more like the Volgrim every day." I felt irritation at how casually he brushed off my concerns. I felt that these issues were quite serious, as a heavily augmented person myself.

Judicator sighed. "Perhaps we are becoming more like them. Is that a bad thing though? Certainly they are warlike and seek to cause our destruction, but what little we have gleaned of their society indicates they have no internal strife, they fight no civil wars, they have abundance for all, they are a post-scarcity society, and they are very logical thinkers. The biggest downsides

I would note are their emotional cues, where they all seem to lack any emotion, which would certainly lend themselves towards conquering all who oppose them."

"They're emotionless parasites who seek genocide for no apparent reason, and they lack individuality..." I paused as another thought came to my mind. "They're basically the Borg."

Judicator shrugged. "Yes, they are our enemies, and I won't defend them. However, you said they have 'no apparent motivation'. That is not correct. They very likely have a big motivation, we just don't know what it might be."

A short silence ensued as I thought about something else. "Why haven't we tried speaking to them? You said before that the very first Volgrim expeditionary force you encountered, you were able to speak with them. Why have you not tried to make contact with them since? What if our entire war arose from a misunderstanding?"

Judicator sighed as he leaned forwards and shifted his gaze at the ground. "If only it were that simple. I've tried, you know? Whenever I appear in their midst, they always attack first, and ask questions later. It's as if they are being coached to attack me on sight and always ignore anything I have to say. I'm the only person who can speak their language, and they just aren't willing to listen to my words. I've long since given up on peace. We're so similar, yet so different."

I chuckled wryly. "Do you remember propaganda during World War II? We're both too young to have been alive for it, but my grandfather told me of it. Americans were told about how evil the *Japs* were, told of their barbarism, and forced to fight them to protect ourselves against their animalistic nature. Obviously they weren't very different from us, but it was the propaganda that divided us. Maybe you're right, and a similar thing is dividing us and the Volgrim. But..."

I paused as I dwelt on all the friends I had lost over the years... all the comrades brutally shredded by the Demonic Variants or ripped apart by blaster fire from the main species. They've destroyed our homes, our countries, our world. They've killed anyone in their way without distinction, and cared not if they were civilian or military. They are the worst. They are monsters.

"...Even if we had the opportunity to reconcile with them now, I don't think I would want to."

Judicator nodded slowly. "And that, my dear friend, is the real reason we won't be able to have peace. It is the reason I don't try anymore. There's just no point. The only course left is to win the war."

"We will win. We can't afford to lose. Too much is at stake."

Judicator chuckled at my words. "If only you knew."

I wonder if I'll ever find out what he means.

Part 267a: Discoveries

Words are easy. Everyone has words they like to use. Anyone can think of words to use in a comeback. The problem is not a lack of words, it's almost always a time constraint. When I look back on battles I've fought in the past, whether against Volgrim or Demon, if ever I had a regret, it was that I hadn't been able to think of the proper word to use in any specific moment. When all the world leaders were killed and I failed to use a barrier to protect them from the kamikaze-like explosion from the Volgrim infiltration forces, I regret that. Often times, it's not a lack of ability that defines how badly I perform, but a lack of time. Given time, with powers like mine, there really isn't anything that could get in my way.

But now I'm finding that even time isn't enough. Even mental function isn't enough. For once, it's a lack of good words that is hampering my progress.

The young woman in front of me is smiling cheerfully at me, though I feel anything but cheerful. This is hardly good news.

"...So because of that, we've managed to scan all over the place and we've figured out that they're actually attacking Earth from various dimensional rifts! They're like gates that connect to other universes, artificial ones to be sure, and they can make them appear anywhere at any time! But the best part is, soon we'll be able to reverse engineer these for our own benefit, and attack them on a second front!"

I cringed at her words but put up a brave smile. "I see. That's, uh, good news. You've done well, Karen. You and your team both."

Despite the lack of enthusiasm in my voice, Karen was still chirping happily as she nudged her wide glasses up her nose with her free hand. "I mean think of it! Soon, our troops won't have to stay spread out all over the world, we can concentrate on continually attacking them from within their hideouts! In fact, we might be able to solve all manner of dimensional problems with this! We could even create new dimensions for ourselves! This changes everything regarding multiverse theory!!" She was practically hopping up and down by this point.

But Karen just didn't understand what this *really* meant. I already knew how the Volgrim were getting here. I already knew they were somehow involved with the Labyrinth and other dimensions. I've seen those other worlds she was speaking of. But worse yet, this was bringing us one step closer to the edge of Angels being discovered. While their help would certainly be helpful in the war, I couldn't imagine much worse than us going down the path to their

extinction. If we discovered how to scan for new dimensions, it really was only a matter of time before we discovered that 'heaven' was not as magical of a place as once thought.

I lack the words. I can't just make everyone here 'forget' their work, they'd find it and start working on it again. Even if I successfully hid the evidence of different universes, another group of people would surely find the evidence instead, ones whose motives might not be so pure.

"Yes. Again, good job Karen." I smiled politely as she bobbled away to go chat with one of the researchers about her findings.

This was the worst possible scenario. Technology is truly fearsome. Once humans discover that angels and demons are *literally* angels and demons, and not 'Volgrim Variants', what will happen?

Obviously, humans will love angels at first. But that would only be the beginning. Once they see a veritable army of angels, they will ask why divine intervention didn't save the lives of their families. Those who have no such misgivings might still begin to think that there was no need for prayer, since angels aren't mystic beings anymore. They would grow used to the presence of angels.

And that's only the first step. Once humans discover the presence of angels and demons, they will more carefully begin to research the old legends of their existence. Those old paintings by weird artists of the Renaissance would take on whole new meanings. It's very likely they may even discover the existence of spiritual energy, which would likely lead to not only anti-demon weaponry, but anti angelic weaponry... and possibly weaponry that could kill me.

The good news is, I've stored away a clone or two for just this purpose. If I am going to die, they will awaken and absorb my body and my memories. My suit should also be reinforced against such weapons, so it's likely they won't be able to hurt me, despite all of that.

And then... there's the matter of that Cryopod. I still remember the day I laid eyes upon a visage of myself, frozen in suspended animation. Why did my body appear at the instant I used my powers the first time? What exactly was going on there?

No point asking too many questions. The Cryopod is safely stored aboard the Mothership, where Harold keeps a constant eye on it.

Have I really changed anything yet? The only solid thing I know that has a mostly definitive date attached to it is the destruction of Earth, or Earth's ecosystem, or humanity as a whole, by the end of the 24th century. That is all.

I just don't know. I don't know anything.

My communicator lights up inside my HUD as a familiar face appears. "Judicator. I was wondering if you were available to speak for a moment."

"Supreme Admiral Beatrix. A pleasure to hear from you." My face doesn't show up in her visual feed, instead she sees my helmet front. "I heard you were on leave due to a family member's illness."

"It's fine, turns out it was a minor case of heart cancer. We treated it within a few weeks, thanks to those new nanobot cancer treatments for VIP's. It's the doctor's hope that soon mass production will eliminate all forms of cancer soon, not just for the wealthy or connected." Beatrix smiled as she glanced down and tapped some skin-layer buttons, special devices embedded right into her arm that projected holographic images upwards, or they could even tell the time, and do many other sorts of neat things by displaying images right on top of the skin.

Within a few moments, I received a file that she had uploaded to me over the Hypernet. "I need you to put your Hancock on a few of these, and also give some feedback to this plan I drafted regarding the Paris remodeling."

"For the international teleporter index? You know France's prime minister is skittish about teleporters, as are the people of Paris especially. I heard he came under scrutiny recently for his dealings with Finland's leaders and their nuclear arsenal. Just give it some time and he'll be out, and replaced with a new Prime Minister. Parisians aren't fond of how he treated the incident regarding when the Eiffel Tower was crushed anyways, so I can't see him being there much longer."

Beatrix nodded slowly. "Yes, but that could be a while before all the pieces fall into place. We have a war to win, and thousands of refugees are still in need of permanent housing there. If we can convince him to accept being added into the teleporter network, we can deliver relief supplies much more easily and quickly, not to mention improving Paris's economic outlook for tourists."

I nodded as I allowed my eye to be scanned to imprint my digital signature on the relevant papers. "Okay, that's a good point. I'll look it over. Anything else?"

Beatrix licked her lips slowly as her eyes gazed away for a few moments. "...Well, not exactly. I'm still not happy, you know. It's been a long twenty-six years. For a quarter of a century, we've fought these alien invaders, and we're moving further and further away from peace, towards total destruction of our race or theirs. While I'd prefer humanity win if one of those two outcomes had to occur, I can't say it fills me with joy to eradicate or enslave another species, especially an intelligent and sentient one."

I uncomfortably averted my eyes from hers, though she couldn't see them from behind my visor. "Well, there's not much we can do about that. They won't listen to reason. They attack me on sight. I have no way to bridge the gap."

Beatrix huffed slightly but seemed to resolutely accept it. "Haaah, no point arguing. It can't be helped, I guess. I just thought it might be worth a shot. Thank you for all your efforts, Judicator. I, of all people, understand the time you've had to sacrifice for the betterment of humanity. You're doing the best you can."

I nodded slowly, as my eyes glanced up and looked at hers through my visor's viewscreen. "Yeah... the best I can do. Thanks, Beatrix, for giving me a call. Here are the signed documents, as requested."

"No problem. Beatrix out." Her feed disappeared with a click a few moments later, as she received the files.

Was she right? I left the office for the scientific division aboard the Johannesburg Moon Base and walked towards my private quarters. *Have I really done all that I possibly can do to attempt to secure peace?*

Can I really say that I have? I haven't tried simply using 'Peace', or 'Pacify', or any other such words. What if using those simply ended the conflict? What if they *didn't*? Even if they did, it would truly confirm that I possessed godlike powers. I've never once used my abilities to influence another person's mind against their will. It seems so wrong. It reminds me of the thought police. But, at the same time, if it saved millions, even billions of lives, would it not be worth trying? If you lose your free will though, can you truly be called sentient?

I don't know what to do. I just don't know. For now, I'll just prepare myself for the launching of our first Galactic Exploration Force. The name fills me with unease. I protested against it, but for some reason, people seemed hellbent on adopting it. "Britannian Galaxy Explorers discriminates against the countries not in our coalition, and this is a group of explorers from all over the planet! We'll use the more inclusive name that allows all to participate properly!"

But they don't understand why I warned them against using that name. And as for why they seemed to almost desperately prefer it? I can't understand it. I never failed them once, and now they doubt my judgement?

I can't see the future changing, especially for the better. I just can't.

Part 268a: Familiar Face

Satan kept his expression even as he walked down the hallways, leading the five Founders of the Volgrim, along with their hundred elite Royal Guards down the twisting and meandering pathways of his labyrinth. Over the last decade, he had furiously expanded it, adding many more lodgings and accommodations to keep the Volgrim available for combat at a moment's notice.

There was no point trying to lead them off course or down any back paths, as the Founders appeared to have photographic memories. Of course, Satan had plans to combat this in the near future, but for now, there wasn't much point using deceit. The more he thought about it, the more he realized just how weak and pathetic the Volgrim were. He could easily crush all five of them with a single thought. At least the Angels and Gods were a legitimate threat, but the Volgrim were as weak as the humans, weaker even, because the humans were extremely inventive when it came to the art of war.

No, Satan had bigger plans for these mind-reading sociopaths. Just one little spell made it possible to split his conscious and unconscious minds apart, allowing them to read faked pleasant thoughts of how he enjoyed their company and their partnership, while secretly he plotted against them every step of the way.

It would all be too easy.

Finally, their group arrived in the main room of the Central Rift Repository, where his labyrinth connected to many other dimension and locations, especially so when it came to places on Earth. The gates would be somewhat moveable, able to shift around within a twenty-mile radius of their initial placement location on the planet, but moving any further would require tremendous spiritual energy. As long as it kept the humans guessing, the rifts were doing their jobs.

First Founder, Unarin, was the first to speak when they arrived. "So, then, Satan... we've followed along. What is this surprise you wished to show us? I'm not one who is fond of being left in the dark."

Satan grinned as he beckoned towards an inactive rift beacon, its flat platform as dull and lifeless as all the other ones. The platforms could be activated and deactivated with no cost once constructed, but their initial construction always exacted a heavy toll, either in blood, or in spiritual energy. "We finally did it. We located the dimension the Angels reside in. And now, this portal is ready to open so that we can rain fire upon our oppressors."

Unarin nodded. "I see. This is excellent news. When shall we start readying our elite forces?"

Satan shook his head. "Not yet. Not right now. Listen, your people are being absolutely slaughtered wholesale by the humans. If you can't take on humans, you will stand no chance against angels and gods. You need a major wartime upgrade before you can call yourselves ready for this battle."

Dosena cocked an eyebrow as she stifled a glare towards the red-skinned devil before her. "Is that so? Are you calling us... weak?"

Satan returned the expression as he pivoted to face her. "Are you calling your forces strong? Singular human warriors outfitted in those battle suits are demolishing your people by the thousands. I would hardly call the humans strong, but they are exterminating your species at an alarming rate."

Dosena didn't even hesitate, as an unnatural sounding laugh involuntarily blasted from her throat. "HA! That is a most amusing train of thought, Devil. As of the last 30 orbital periods on our planet since entering this fairly insignificant war, we have lost less than one percent of one percent of our battle forces, let alone our entire population. We have trillions and trillions of Volgrim willing to fight and die for the glory of our people. If anything, we have been merely testing the will of the Humans, to gauge how we should defeat them."

Satan snickered at her response. "Kukuku... strong words for one humiliated twice by those apes. Your people will be annihilated once the humans arrive at your planet. They know where it is, you know, and they will be launching their assault very soon."

Dosena's smile faded and she simply nodded nonchalantly. "Let them come. They won't like what we've been hiding. The dregs we've sent to battle them on Earth, to attempt to destabilize their planet, those were nothing. When they find out our true power, they will rue the day they chose us as their enemy."

Satan decided not to respond, but secretly he laughed at her in his mind. *Stupid fool. You won't get the chance. I'll be the one to finish your race off. The humans will just be a warmup.*

Cinculu, the fifth founder, decided to add in his two cents. "Satan, you mentioned that we would need better technology to combat the humans. What were you referring to?"

Satan's grin returned as he looked over at the fifth. "Well, as it just so happens, not all humans like the current regime. Some are much more friendly to our cause, due to certain... *happenings.*"

Satan flicked an eye over towards one of the demon attendants on the other side of the room. "You! Bring her here!"

The demon jerked stiffly as he felt Satan's aura directed at him, nodded brusquely, and then ran off into another room, returning moments later with a young-looking female human. She had a red-colored short-cropped hairstyle, along with a neatly ironed and carefully pressed white labcoat, followed by a wide-brim set of glasses, though based on her likely age, it's likely the glasses were more of a fashion choice than to actually help her see.

"Satan. Nice to see you again." The young woman spoke with a surprisingly dry voice, her inflection sounding like sandpaper on cardboard. Her voice was very raspy, like she was a chain smoker for fifty straight years.

"Marie, so glad you could come to meet the Volgrim emissaries." Satan smoothly walked over to the young woman and placed his hand on her back as he beckoned with the flat of his hand towards the five Volgrim Founders. "In order of their rank, from first to fifth, we have Unarin, the first, Dosen, the second, Trayza, the third, Cuanali, the fourth, and Cinculu, the fifth."

Marie's eyes glazed over at the barrage of names, but she nodded slowly. "Right. I'm Marie Becker, a scientist on Earth. I dabble in... many fields."

Unarin shifted his body slightly towards the tall, wispy young human. He had never actually spoken to one before, only that one Elder, Nufaris, had done such a thing, along with a few Volgrim who had been interrogated but managed to self-destruct before they could reveal information to the enemy. He found the young female to be... small. Very unimposing. These were the enemies they were having such trouble crushing?

"Human Marie, it is good speak to you." He spoke as best as he could using the broken bits of human dialect he had memorized. Shifting from Volgarian to human speech was difficult. He had ever heard rumors that humans spoke more than 500 distinct languages, while the Volgrim only spoke one unified language. What a mess.

"Your grammar could use some improvement, but I've heard worse." Marie blandly offered a critique regarding his English skills with no hesitation whatsoever towards his position among Volgarians or any fear towards what power he might possess. Truly a courageous human.

While he could not speak the human languages very well, all of the Volgrim had downloaded the basic essentials of human language into their minds some years before, thanks to Satan's hard work compiling a list of their languages along with the most commonly used words in each unique dialect. Even if they didn't speak the human languages very well, the Volgrim could understand what the humans were saying easily.

"Is good that you understand the words I am speak. What to offer us do you have?" Unarin kept his tone neutral, yet pleasant. Allies and moles were always useful among an enemy one

wished to conquer. Only a fool would turn down their help, though if they had betrayed their former comrades once, they were quite likely to betray their new ones as well, if the going got tough.

Marie raised both eyebrows inquisitively. "Not 'offer', I wish to 'trade'. I don't give my talent out for free. You should count yourselves lucky I would consider you over my own people."

"I see. It is trade that you want, then what do you offer and what is the request you make?" Unarin silently cursed himself that he wasn't able to speak fluently in all the human languages yet. It was unbecoming for a great leader to sound like an oaf. The only good news was that humans were less intelligent, being unable to speak a word of Volgarian whatsoever. He still possessed greater knowledge than they did.

"Well, this might sound stupid, but... I wish to rule the Earth, along with all the humans. To have infinite money, all that other silly stuff. If you can give me that, then I'll give you what you want."

Satan raised an eyebrow at her words. "Really? To rule the world? I never took you for the type, Marie."

She glared at him. "Of course I don't want to rule the world, *imbecile*. It was a joke. Idiot demons, with pea brains that can't understand sarcasm." As she huffed at him, Satan felt his annoyance bubble upwards slightly. *This human is mocking me...*

He felt his ten limbs start to rise on their own as she continued to speak down to him. "Obviously, the only thing I want is more rare metals and chemicals, so that I can create ever more bizarre and diverse-... hmm? You seem quite angry, Satan. Did something I say get under your skin?"

Satan suddenly noted with alarm that Marie was not looking at *him*, her eyes appeared to look behind him, towards... his invisible arms? But that couldn't be possible. They were invisible, entirely. Only one had ever been able to actually see them as visible...

She grinned as she saw the look of confusion on his face. "Now now, Satan dearest, you're not thinking of doing something stupid, like strangling the life out of me, are you? No matter how strong you think you are, it would be most unwise."

"How... how are you able to perceive the ten hands of my seventh evolution?" Satan grimaced as he realized she was following their movements easily.

"Idiot. I've been aware of all four types of energy for years. You don't think these glasses are just for show, do you? I can mentally switch to one, two, or any number of energy types all at once. Of course, that's not the only trick I've got up my sleeve. But perhaps you forgot we were

allies?" Marie sneered at his dumbfounded expression as she turned back to the Volgrim, ignoring Satan's presence completely.

"The buffoon over here fancies himself the most powerful being alive, but he's merely *a* powerful being. There are different types of power. It's not what you use, it's how you use it. Have I piqued your curiosity yet?"

Unarin narrowed his eyes towards the small human standing before him. *This one is quite dangerous. Size doesn't matter when one is fighting with their mind.*

"Yes, you give me much interest. Speak more on this is what we should."

Marie's smile slowly faded as she pulled out a small handheld object from within one of the pockets of her labcoat. "If you wish to defeat the angels and the gods, you won't be able to do it without an energy nullifier, which I just so happen to have."

Satan felt his blood cool noticeably as he looked at the object in her hand. Whatever that device was, it was not just for killing angels and gods. It was something to be feared.

Part 269a:

The officers on board the Explorer-class ship, Excelsior, were prepping for their first voyage, as the crew of 1,200 shifted to and fro, gearing up for their launch in just a few hours.

Only a few days ago, the EPS (Earth Protective Shield) was completed and came online, and the offensive fleet that was to head towards Volgarius to attack them on their home territory had launched shortly afterwards.

Things are moving quickly.

I stand now before the Gods and Angels once again, as I tell them about what is going on down on Earth. A bunch of them are sitting at the usual place at the Great Table as it's known, mumbling and nodding as I give my explanation.

Britannia, the goddess of the Times, who I had come to meet when she gave me Excalibur, smiled expectantly as I spoke. "That's great news! As more and more countries join the Brittanian Empire, my power grows. Exploring the space around Earth is also good, we need a refuge in case the worst should happen on our homeworld."

"Hold off on talk like that. I don't like to hear it." Zeus scowled at Britannia. "I don't want to hear anyone say 'if the Earth should be destroyed' or any other such things, am I clear? It makes me very uneasy."

Britannia waved her hand at him and rolled her eyes. "For heaven's sake, you're acting like the superstitious humans do when they start thinking about 'bad luck' and 'jinxing' themselves. We have a competent, even *powerful* Hero here, I think we will be able to handle anything the demons and Volgrim throw at us."

I shifted on my feet as Zeus grumbled under his breath. Gabriel took a sip of wine and then set it back down. "So, Jason, we brought you here today for a good reason. Can you guess what it is?"

I shrugged at him as I finally sat down at the end of the table uneasily. The atmosphere had been very odd up to this point. The gods seemed very despondent, yet hopeful. It was as if they had made a difficult decision, yet had decided to live with the consequences. "Well, uh, perhaps you decided to make me an honorary god?"

Gabriel's smile faltered as he flicked his gaze over to Britannia, who shrugged and looked away, before Gabriel looked back to me. "I mean, I suppose if you wanted it might be possible but, err... no."

Aw... *man*. "Well in that case, I have no clue."

Gabriel's smile vanished entirely as he eyed me. "We've decided to join in the war, out of... necessity. We will start helping humans very soon in battle against the Volgrim, but only in important circumstances."

I felt my jaw drop slightly as I picked it back up and reattached it. "You're joking. That is to say... you shouldn't, though."

"Yes, we're aware of your predictions about the Earth dying, we have to take the risk though. Humanity no longer is giving us enough thought energy output to survive. If we wait much longer, we're going to start dying out en-masse." Gabriel lowered his gaze as he stared at the cup in front of him. "These are dark times for us. We face the possibility of extinction by way of fighting our current two enemies and losing, by way of humanity not supplying us with the energy we need, and by humanity outright exterminating us if they deem us a threat. In fact, we no longer see any winning paths, other than to join the fray and hope our appearance inspires humans to begin praying more fervently. If we're lucky, they will be able to give us enough thought energy to actually start gaining spiritual energy again. Right now, we're barely even, and soon we will begin losing it, faster and faster. From our end, it's quite hopeless."

Gabriel went on to explain to me his plan: Under my command, they would join in important battles fighting amongst the humans to bolster their spirits, then returning to heaven quickly, so as to not make humans grow too comfortable around them.

"I understand. I fear the extinction of the angels will happen if we pursue this route, but you are correct... the extinction is looking more likely every day... almost as if it was fated to happen." I chewed on my lip as my eyes glazed over.

"Well, personally, I think it's a grand idea! Too bad you won't live long enough to see it bear fruit."

From the center of the room, a voice spoke out suddenly, as a familiar figure appeared in a flash of light. Satan stood on the table before us, as everyone jumped to their feet.

"What in the name of Heaven?!" Zeus summoned lightning in his hand as he raised his hand up to strike the demon down.

"There's no need for that." Satan teleported in an instant directly behind me, but my spatial vision was able to track his movement and I jerked to my left as I spun around to face him.

"Satan. I thought I might have killed you. I guess I can't be that lucky, when there's no body to be found."

Satan chuckled as his eyes darkened. "This isn't the time for pleasantries. I just wanted to tell the gods that my preparations are finally complete. This is the day you all perish. Farewell!"

Without waiting for a response, Satan vanished, as if he had stepped into another dimension instead of teleporting, he wholly disappeared from my spatial vision in an instant.

"What was that about?!" Gabriel glowered at the spot where Satan had been standing. "Just what did he mean by that?"

I started to pose a theory, but at that moment alarms lit up in my suit. "WARNING! PILOT JASON, PROJECTILE INBOUND FROM ABOVE! TAKE COVER!"

My spatial vision suddenly started tracking a missile flying directly at the Temple of Artemis, as I quickly coiled my legs and leaped upwards, sailing a few hundred feet past the open roof and above the temple just in time to see what resembled a nuclear warhead aimed directly at the gods!

Deflecting was a bad idea, too many could die wherever it landed! Only one option rushed to my mind. " **INERT!** "

The missile continued on its path directly towards the temple. In a single breath, it blasted past me and smashed into the ground, the gods narrowly leaping out of the way in time. As I fell back to the ground, my spatial vision rapidly examined it, and I felt a sinking feeling in my gut. No exotic particles were present. This wasn't a bomb, it was a-

Before I realized what was happening, the missile suddenly opened up, the side of it blasting outwards, as a strange device inside activated.

WEEEE WEEEE WEEEE

A loud screeching sound emitted from it, causing all of the gods in the room to fall into convulsions as they fell to their knees, and then went totally limp, flopping on the floor.

What the hell was that?! As I fell back down, I hit the ground with a thud and dashed over to the device. It was still emitting that awful screeching noise, so I hit it full force, smashing it to pieces.

A few seconds later, the immortals in the room stumbled back up to their feet, as they breathed heavily. "That... I felt the life drain from my body in the blink of an eye..." Gabriel seemed quite shaken. The feeling of powerlessness must have been quite overwhelming.

I glanced at the device again as my helmet front closed up. " *Inspect.* "

A list of readings appeared in my mind, but they were too complicated for me to fully understand. Still, I got the gist of it, thanks to the intelligence the Crown of Solomon had given me in the past. This was an energy nullifier. It seemed to cause any being in a short distance to

lose the ability to move, completely neutralizing them, based on their spiritual energy levels. Luckily my suit gave me protection from the device, but the gods were totally powerless against it.

Was this a warning shot? Or maybe...

From outside, there was a loud ruckus, as sounds of explosions were heard in the distance. I stood up quickly, as did the gods and the archangels, as we all turned to rush outside.

A massive amount of enemies were visible some miles away, the flatness of Heaven allowing us to see their army clearly. Volgrim and demon alike appeared to be flooding through rifts that had appeared in the far distance. I couldn't make out exactly what was going on, but getting closer would solve that problem.

"Let's go. This appears to be an important battle." Zeus was in all business mode, as he slapped his golden chest armor, bearing the blackened mark of a lightning bolt across the front. "This has been a long time coming."

Part 270a: Barbarism

I am old. Very old.

Not as old as the archangels, or even the gods, of course, but still exceedingly old. I lived through the wars of the second era, and the third era, and now hundreds of eras later as well. I have seen many things, and I have killed many with my own hands.

And yet, for a demon as hardened in combat and as world weary who has seen as many things as I have, this is still so... stomach churning. I must say that this is not how I imagined this battle would work.

I recently read about the atrocities humans committed against their own in their second world war. No demon, angel, god, or dare I permit myself to guess, not even a Volgrim would treat their own or the enemy as the humans treated their own kind during those awful wars. I suppose the saying 'anything goes in war' was coined by somebody who lived through that era of barbarism, but I still suspect even they would find this to be unsettling.

Thanks to that strange device the human woman showed us, we have the ability to completely nullify an angel's ability to fight. I'm not into the mechanical stuff like those young demons are, but I can understand the general way in which it works. Something about their unique spiritual energy backfires inside them, rendering their entire body immobile, as they fall to the ground, unable to lift even a finger.

I hate the angels and the gods. I really do. They butchered my brethren when they caught even a whiff of free-thinking. But when you can render an entire army totally helpless, and the only thing you have left to worry about is how quickly you can turn their bodies into mulch... it doesn't sit right with me.

It's not that I sympathize with the angels. By no means! I just prefer a foe who can at least offer a modicum of resistance, no matter how pitiful. Worse, we're not even killing real angels right now. These are pseudo-angels, humans born long after the end of the Great War in Heaven. They really have no skin in the game, and were brought here by the despicable gods and angels to do their dirty work for them. And, unlike even the imps of my people, these pseudo-angels have no ability to leave Heaven. They are imprisoned here, until they are sent out to die.

I cannot simply allow this to happen.

"Satan." I walk up to our dear leader, who is once again exercising the abilities of Hercules, the first Hero he ever killed in combat. The ability to command his armies all at once, granting

them unparalleled unstoppable power.

Satan's eyes twitch to and fro, as he looks from one end of the carnage to the other. "Yes, Agares? I'm busy right now. Can it wait?"

A head is ripped from a pseudo-angel nearby and hurled to the rear of the field, as it smashes into the ground, exploding in a bloody mess just a few dozen feet away from the both of us. I glance at it, but Satan doesn't pay it the slightest bit of attention.

"My lord... this is unbecoming of us. Slaughtering angels and gods that are unable to fight back... we're no better than they were when they killed our forefathers. Surely we can fight at least somewhat fairly?"

Satan's face scrunched up as he flicked his eyes over to me. I could tell he didn't want to have this discussion. "Elder Agares, I have always respected your input, especially in matters of war. However, the time to object was before we entered the battlefield, not afterwards. Further, we are not the villains here. An eye for an eye, that is the demon way. They did in fact slaughter our forefathers, so we will enact full revenge on them as way of repayment. Do I make myself clear?"

Satan's last words were strangled, as if to threaten me with his mere tone of voice. I leaned heavily on my gnarled wooden cane as I nodded quietly. "Yes... my lord."

Satan went back to ignoring me as his eyes roamed forwards to the clouds soaked red with the blood of his most hated enemies. Of course he wouldn't listen to my counsel. I should have mentioned my objections earlier, as he said. He was right.

Still, I looked around the battlefield with saddened old eyes as I watched tens of thousands of angels falling like wheat to the scythe. I started to turn around to walk away, but Satan spoke up. "Hold. A moment, if you will. The Hero is coming, and I am busy guiding the army. Would you be so kind as to slow him down for a while? Distract him. Take his focus off me, if you would. I will deal with him when the time is ready."

I slowly turned back around to Satan, as my knees creaked. "Ah, but I am just an old demon, worn out and tired. I don't think I would be able to do much against such a young and powerful Hero. Perhaps you should ask Bael or Diablo? Surely they would be better equipped to handle one with such immeasurable power?"

Satan sneered as he stifled a chuckle. "A good jest, but let's end the charade. You will do just fine against him, Lord of Reptiles. It was not a request, it was a direct order."

I felt a sparkle gleam in my eye as he spoke. "You'd order a poor old man to his death? For shame. However, as my lord, I will obey your command. I'll try to slow him down, if only just for a few moments, even if it should kill this old man."

As I turned and hobbled away on my cane, Satan chuckled quietly. "Yes, yes. Just don't kill him, please. I need to have some fun too, you know."

* * *

As I flew forwards using my Hypersuit's flight system to conserve my own energy, I felt panic rising at how easily the pseudo-angels were falling. My suit quickly brought up estimated stats... two million dead. To be fair, out of tens of billions, it was a small number, but not a single demon or Volgrim had died yet. This was a veritable holocaust with how easily they were cleaning shop.

Zeus and Gabriel flew alongside me, as we raced towards the enemy. While only a few miles away, I constantly kept flying down to smash the devices that were being shot randomly all over the place, each device completely incapacitating any angels or gods within a certain area of its presence. The good news was that they were quite vulnerable to being smashed, but the bad news was that I was the only one who could smash them, and the enemy was shooting them around far faster than I could break them!

"Fuck! I need help! Ah, wait, I've got an idea!" I quickly landed in a small clearing where the angels weren't bunched too close together. Aiming my hand up in the air, I quickly cast a spell.

" SUMMON! "

As I cast it, over and over, my clones began to appear, one by one. The energy cost of bringing them to me was quite small luckily, so soon I had over three hundred hypersuit-outfitted clones to help in the battle.

Quickly I yelled out. "All clones! Immediately clone yourselves now, then have those clones clone themselves!"

They nodded as they quickly took note of what was going on around them. Seconds later, their numbers swelled from 300 to 600, and then to 900. It would have to do.

"Spread out, destroy all the energy nullifier devices you can find! We can't let the demons and Volgrim kill our friends!"

Within seconds, all of them were speeding off to seek these devices. I could have summoned more clones, but the lowest level clones would be down to pitiful amounts of energy, and in one fell swoop, I had taken us from 7th level cloning to 9th level. I wasn't sure what the immediate repercussions might be, nor did I wish to find out what the long-term effects would be either.

I quickly located the leader. Satan. As I thought, he was over with his other generals, a terrifying fighting force, one I was not keen on attacking so soon after he had crushed me swiftly last time. Still, to kill a snake, you have to cut off its head.

I dashed forwards, leaping into the air as I ignited my jets to blast over towards him.

A few moments later, something odd happened. My forward momentum turned into downwards momentum, and I suddenly careened at the ground, as if a massive anvil were attached to my body.

BOOM!

I hit the ground with a tremendous impact, dust flying up in the air in all directions as my body felt the pressure that had yanked me downwards release. Zeus and Gabriel had continued flying ahead to attack the enemy head on, but as I raised my head up, I found myself lying a few feet away from... an old man.

"Greetings, young one. My name is Agares. Forgive me for pulling you in, but I was hoping we might have a nice, splendid chat."

An old demon stood before me, as I pulled myself up to a standing position. With a long white beard and very bushy eyebrows, combined with a receding hairline, and an unimposing hunched posture accentuated by a beaten-up wooden cane, he cut quite the miniscule figure in front of my Herculean body.

"Sorry, but while the demons may be my enemy, I'm not in the habit of attacking the elderly. If you move out of my way, I won't hurt you."

I coiled my legs to spring up, the impact from a few seconds before having caused me no damage whatsoever. In the blink of an eye, I shot upwards, leaping over the strange old man the final quarter-mile towards Satan's lookout, where he appeared to be facing down Zeus and Gabriel both.

Before I could clear much distance, I felt an invisible arm grab hold of my foot, yanking *hard* as I was suddenly pulled in reverse back to my original jumping location, once again smashing onto the ground with a loud *crash*.

Now I lay on my back, once again facing that strange old man as he stroked his beard. Suddenly, I perceived a slight dark aura engulfing his body as he eyed me with cold, unforgiving eyes.

"It's not polite to disrespect your elders like that, mortal."

Part 271a: Passion

"What are you playing at, old man? Do you want to fight?"

I eyed the aged demon carefully. Despite his looks, I'd learned in the past that things were not always what they seemed. Remembering a certain crocodile and how he had shattered my expectations brought a rather nostalgic memory to mind.

Still, even as I stood up and eyed the short old demon up and down, I couldn't really find him 'intimidating'. His diminutive presence meant that I would have to knock him out, but I didn't want to hurt him too badly. I'm a sap when it comes to respecting my elders.

"Alright, grandpa. Listen, if you want to talk, I'll talk, but can it wait until I beat the devil out of Satan? This is really not the time."

Agares smirked at me. "You're not afraid of a little old man are you?" From behind me, a pseudo-angel screamed in pain as she was cut down violently and torn into pieces by vicious scyther variants. I whipped my head back to see what was going on, and noted with alarm that the Volgrim were deploying some sort of mecha battle armors onto the field, more bulky than my own Hypersuit, but still powerful enough to tear the angels to shreds.

Luckily, my clones seemed to be holding out.

I turned back to the old man to catch a slight glimpse of disgust on his face as he eyed the carnage behind me. When he saw me looking at him, it quickly vanished.

"I'm not afraid of you, not in the slightest. I simply don't have time for this... whatever it is you want to talk about."

"Keh, youth are always so impatient, always in a rush. Listen, boy, I'm going to tell you something that might surprise you, just the slightest bit." Agares turned his chin up slightly as he said this. "Not all demons like war, and even some of us demon generals aren't fond of it, you see? I've been fighting gods, angels, titans, humans, and heroes for too damn long! This old man wants to settle down with some nice demon girls, maybe some human girls, and call it a life, you see?"

I blinked at him slowly. "All right, you're definitely insane. You picked one hell of a time to have a midlife crisis, old man. I don't have time for this." I started to turn my back on him, but suddenly he appeared in front of me as I looked in the opposite direction.

"Hey! I didn't say you could leave, idiot. You can't just walk away when I'm talking to you." Agares glared at me as he licked his lips. "Forget about this battle, your stupid clones are doing

all the fighting anyway. One more o' ye ain't gonna do a thing to help."

"I don't have time for this! Get out of my way!" I felt my irritation bubble over as I jumped at him, swinging at him with an open palm to slap the old codger out of my way.

Instead, I hit nothing but air. He was suddenly gone, as I heard a voice behind me. "Oy... did you just... take a swing at me..."

It wasn't a question. I could almost taste the angry edge to his voice, but I had just about enough of his games as well.

"Nice dodging, grandpa. If you stay out of my way, I won't have to make the next one connect."

"The youth of this generation weren't made like the ones from a few prior. Respect has gone out the window..."

As he finished speaking, I felt a sudden SLAP across the side of my visor, as I went flying to the side, tumbling end over end, landing face down in the clouds.

"Jesus, you hit like a truck, old man!"

I heard a different voice speak up this time though, a female voice. "It wasn't he that gave you a walloping, little man."

I quickly jerked my head up to see Samantha's face staring down at me, just in time to see her rearing her leg back for a mighty kick. There was no avoiding this one. I simply braced myself with all my might, as her foot drove deep into my stomach, blasting me straight up in the air like a wild and crazy field goal that went too out of control.

My suit's alarms screamed at me as the autopilot took over for a moment, ejecting blasts of heat to stop my crazy spinning that was making me horribly nauseous. As I righted myself, I jerked back as I saw Samantha's face again, as she had jumped up right in front of me, her fists both raised above my body, as she slammed down, *hard*.

I smashed into the ground faster than I could even register the movement, my entire body spinning dizzily as I lay there, just trying to register what had happened.

"Belial, Satan gave this task to me. You shouldn't interfere." Agares grumbled at her as she landed a few seconds later, her impact smooth and graceful, as if it had been a tiny hop over a puddle instead of a two hundred foot fall down to incredibly hard clouds.

"I'm bored. Satan didn't give me anyone fun to fight, and he's having all the fun beating up the gods by himself. This hero will have to amuse me for a while." She was of course wearing another ridiculously revealing outfit, just like the one she had worn in the future, though this

was more of a white silken undergarment one might see in a lingerie catalog, rather than those strange fetishy black 'strings' she wore when I knew her.

I jumped to my feet quickly, after taking a few seconds to reorient my positioning. "Samanth- err, Belial. Nice to uh, err well, I mean, uh-" I found myself slopping my words badly, not sure whether to greet her in a friendly manner, or treat her as an enemy. She surely regarded me as an enemy, though I couldn't say the same for myself towards her...

"Excellent, you heard him say my name. You're such an observant human." She rolled her eyes as she flicked her long black hair over her shoulder to her backside. "Come now, Satan has told me you were a foe who nearly killed him. Let's see how you fare against the strongest demoness in Hell!"

I gazed at her up and down carefully. One thing I knew from the sparring I'd done with her in the future was that she was unbelievably strong, specifically in physical strength. If Hercules was supposed to be the strongest Hero, then Samantha, err, Belial... she was supposed to be the strongest demon, by her own admission.

But, I only ever lost to her a few times. She has good speed and tremendous strength, along with an arsenal of magical abilities, but she's more of a brute-force fighter. Beating her should be quite doable...

I just don't want to kill her. If I kill her, that could change the future tremendously.

As I stood there dumbly thinking thoughts about the future, she scowled at me. "Not going to make the first move, huh? Probably too afraid to hit a girl. Fucking humans, let me beat those thoughts out of your thick head!"

She dashed forwards at me and I recognized it as a feint she had pulled on me during many training maneuvers. Her right fist pulled back like she was going to punch with it, but her left fist was already cocked and ready to strike where the opponent didn't see it coming.

I dodged away from her left fist, towards her right, which caught her off guard. Deciding to go with the flow, she instead punched with her right fist at me. "You dodged right into your death, idiot!"

"No." I spoke one simple word as I deftly batted her right fist away from myself, delivering a hard slap to her back as she stumbled forwards.

Of course, it didn't hurt her, but she jerked her head up, miffed that I had so expertly deflected her initial attack. "Satan wasn't kidding, you're a talented fighter."

"No. I just have... experience... with this sort of thing..."

Damn. Now that I'm face to face with her, I want to tell her about myself, about us... I can't bear to seriously fight her. If it just meant a fight of attrition, I could easily hold her off with my foreknowledge of her fighting techniques for a very long while.

But there's a war raging. To my alarm, I note that while the demon/Volgrim death toll has finally risen to one million, the angels and gods have already lost 47.3 million warriors. Not good. I don't have time to keep fighting these two, and while I might be able to kill them... I don't want to, at least not Samantha.

"Hmm?" Agares suddenly glances over in my direction. "Something just occurred to me. You initially treated Belial here as if you might know her. Then you deflected a feint that has skewered many a foe, and you did it as if it were muscle memory..."

She glanced over at Agares quickly. "Old croc', what are you trying to say? Out with it!"

I felt my stomach churn as the old man had a gleam in his eye.

"He's from the future, you know. I think he's fought you before. You two might even be mortal enemies in the time he comes from."

I had braced myself for the worst, but... it seems he was only halfway on the right track. *Lucky.*

But I quickly came to a decision as they looked at each other and back to me. In the blink of an eye, my visor closed, as I aimed my word magic at both of them. " **SLEEP!** "

The two of them suddenly started wobbling, as their eyes started forcing themselves shut.

"What... what the devil is... is this... mag... ic..." Belial groggily stumbled forwards as she collapsed in a heap at my feet. The old man lasted a few seconds longer, as he fought mightily against the force my magic placed on his brain.

"Gah... fiend... you'll kill us... while we sleep?! You're no... better... than the..." He didn't get to finish his sentence, as he fell down in the same ungraceful manner as she did.

"No. I have no quarrel with either of you." I spoke to the two sleeping husks, as I teleported them to the rear of the battlefield, in a small enclave where they wouldn't be seen.

With both of them dead asleep, I had now confirmed something important. Satan had only protected himself against my word magic. Not even his beautiful queen was protected. Why? Was there something going on behind the scenes? What was this game he was playing at?

Ignoring my thoughts, I quickly began to make my way past heaps of corpses towards Satan in the distance. Naturally, he saw me coming, and a grimace sprouted.

I couldn't hear what he was saying, but the Hypersuit lip-read for me.

"Damn. He already took care of the old man. He'll pay for that."

I don't think he'll politely listen while I try to clear up the misunderstanding.

Part 272a:

I arrived just in time to see Satan locked in mortal combat with three clones, as well as Gabriel, Zeus, and Raphael.

Of course, Satan wasn't alone. Aiding him were two of his demon generals, ones I didn't recognize, but who my latent telepathy identified as Diablo and Bael.

Bael was one big son of a gun. He was much bigger and more intimidating than Satan, and he swung around a massive demonstone flail, a classic ball and chain weapon that could crush enemies outright if they didn't dodge it. My suit estimated its weight was close to 300 pounds, the weight of a morbidly obese man, and Bael swung it like it was a little stick being wielded by a child.

"Gwa haha! If this thing hits ya, you're gonna be flattened like a pancake!" Bael roared energetically as he smashed his flail downwards at Raphael, one of my clones shoving Raphael out of the way just as the spiked ball crushed the clone underfoot.

Bael's eyes lit up with joy at how easily he had managed to flatten one of my duplicates. "How do you like that feeling, stupid human?! Now you're dead!"

The flail lifted up suddenly and was chucked away like a side of raw beef. My clone stood up and dusted himself off. "You're a loudmouthed idiot. My suit is at 98% integrity. You hardly even scratched it."

Satan scowled at Bael. "Stop with the chatter!" As a clone rushed him and delivered a mighty punch right to his stomach, Satan flinched and was knocked backwards a step, but otherwise he was unharmed. "Keep pounding on him until that suit falls to pieces! It isn't made of ordinary materials!"

Diablo, wielding a red pitchfork, shot a blast of magma from its three tips as his forked tail rooted in the ground to keep himself balanced. "You don't say! No matter what I hit these copycats with, they just keep standing up! Nothing seems to hurt them!"

I jumped into the fight, teleporting behind Bael as I withdrew Excalibur from storage and stabbed forwards, but Bael sensed my presence and dodged. Lucky, because that surprise attack would likely have skewered him. "That's the point! You can't kill what you can't hurt, Satan! Give it up, you don't have time to prep your piercing attack!"

"Fool! Your clones are hardly hurting my generals and myself at all! This is a battle of attrition, and I won't soon lose!" Satan did not smile however, and it appeared both sides were

at quite the stalemate. However, that was exactly what I had been waiting for.

Jumping a dozen feet away from Bael, I aimed Excalibur at his back as he continued to swing his flail at Raphael.

Aiming my telepathy at all my allies in this fight, I spoke quickly. *Guys! I'm going to fire a holy beam from Excalibur! In exactly three seconds, leap into the air! This is your only warning!*

Raphael flicked his eyes over to me, as his surprisingly spry legs coiled below him. Bael, seeing Raphael stop moving for a split second, reared his fist back to strike a blow at him.

Diablo sensed something was amiss, and jerked his head back just in time to see the energy surging in my blade. "Bael! Watch out! He's-!"

Before he could finish his sentence, as if on cue, I sent out my mental order. *JUMP!*

All of the angels and my clones leaped up in the air at the same time as I stabbed forwards with my blade. "EXCALIBUR!"

A blast of white-hot light shot out of the tip, blasting directly through Bael's chest before he knew what had hit him. His mouth shot open in surprise, but he was unable to spit words out due to loss of lungs.

A second later, the light vanished, as Bael stumbled forwards. His mouth opened and closed, but no words came out. Moments later, he fell to his knees, and then on his face, as his flail dropped to his side.

As blood pooled out of him, Satan's hunched body wildly jerked his gaze over at me. "You! That power- you know how to use it?!"

As Gabriel and the rest of the group landed a few feet away, I leveled my sword at Diablo as power again began to glow in the tip. "That's right. Let's make this two for two."

As I said that, suddenly my brain **exploded**. It was as if ten thousand people screamed a high-pitched noise directly into both of my ears at the same time. I don't know what happened then, only that for a few moments, possibly longer, I lost all control of my body, and then I lost consciousness as well.

* * *

Unarin and Dosena strolled up casually towards the group of angels and gods that were fighting Satan's demon generals. Dosena raised an eye as a single one of the hypersuited warriors pulled out a strange long instrument, and then fired a blast of light at one of the demon generals, killing him instantly. Well, based on his life signs, he wasn't dead, but that could be changed easily if he wasn't pulled out of there.

"All right then, I suppose it's time for us to end this farce. Dosena, deploy the Dragoons. Also, neutralize that feisty one with the sword over there." Unarin mentally indicated the one who had shot the beam of light.

Ah, so it's called a 'sword'. I see now. Dosena nodded as she felt for a moment like she had solved a piece of an important puzzle. With the briefest of thoughts, she aimed her telepathic abilities at the human, who appeared to be charging up another of those deadly attacks. With hardly any effort, the human staggered forwards and flopped lifelessly to the ground.

Another moment later, she contacted the Dragoon Corps and gave them the orders to move out. Frankly, it irritated her that Unarin wouldn't just do it himself, but it was best not to question him in matters such as these. His mental abilities might be second to hers, but he was still lightyears beyond all Volgrim other than the other Founders themselves, and possibly a few select Elders. And, barring that, he had other gifts that he could use freely, which Dosena had luckily been able to witness in the Fifth Great War.

Indeed, he was the highest ranked and most powerful of all Volgrim for a reason. She suspected that even this Satan fellow would be hard pressed to kill the one he thought so little of.

As they strolled up to the ground of demons, angels, and clones, Unarin smiled pleasantly at the enemy, an expression she rarely saw him make. 'Rare' being an understatement, the last time was possibly a few thousand orbits ago.

"If you angels and gods would be so kind as to vacate your home, I will refrain from slaughtering you all like the biological weaklings that you are. Otherwise, I can't guarantee your safety for much longer."

One of the clones dashed over and grabbed the one that Dosena had felled. His front visor shut momentarily and then reopened, and just like that, the one she had incapacitated groggily woke back up.

Hmm? When his visor shut, for a moment I lost all contact with his mind. I felt a strange energy as well, something alien. Was that some special ability that he used?

Dosena icily glared at the clone who had revived the other suited fighter. She noted that these were not the ordinary humans they had seen countless times on the frontlines, but they were clones of the same individual, one who seemed to possess a strange alien energy.

According to Satan, this was known as Heroic Energy, which was separate from the energy that demons and angels used, but similar in its effects. It came from the same source, but Satan never went into specifics regarding how it worked. Very smart, considering he needed all the help he could get when it came time to fight off the Volgrim who would come to collect.

"Unarin, Dosena. You arrived at the perfect time." Satan calmly stood up tall as he turned away from the Founders to eyeball his foes. "Since you're here now, I assume that you've already activated the backup plan?"

Raphael glanced over at the King of the Gods, Zeus, as if saying something telepathically to him. Dosena detected no such telepathic activity, but one could never be too careful around primitives.

"Yes. The Dragoons are launching. They will be here in..." He paused as I fed him the time telepathically. "...two minutes, Earth time. Powering up their bioreactors takes quite the effort, as you already know."

Satan nodded as he took a step backwards, away from the angels and the humans. "Good. We'll take our leave then. Give my demons time to retreat. We don't wish to be caught in the crossfire."

Unarin nodded as he shot a stray thought at Dosena. She flicked her eyes over knowingly. *Yes, if only the demons knew what was coming.*

"You have until they arrive. Begin the tactical retreat. We'll take over from here."

The human whom Dosena had mind-bombed earlier spoke up, an edge of nervousness in his voice. "A r-retreat, huh? I knew you didn't have it in you, Satan."

Satan rolled his eyes at the human. "In minutes, that insult will mean little, coming from a dead man." In the blink of an eye, Satan vanished, dragging along his generals with him into a portal, including the one with the impaled chest.

The human dug his feet into the ground, as his visor closed. For a moment, Dosena once again sensed his mental presence disappear and then reappear.

She quietly wondered why this kept happening. Oh well, a mystery for another day.

Part 273a:

" Immunity."

Right after Satan left, I had finally gotten my bearings and realized that one of the two Volgrim had blasted me with a massive telepathic attack. Using my wordsmithing, I quickly gave myself protection from her telepathy, wondering why I didn't think of doing that first.

Of all things, a telepathic attack was my biggest weakness? I've been fighting demons for fifty years of my biological existence through time, and I still accidentally find ways to be surprised.

Raphael sidled up besides me as the two Volgrim commanders approached. I recognized by the dress they wore and how their telepathy levels were far above my own, to the point where I could see no part of their minds, that they were likely two of the Founders who ruled over all other Volgrim.

Raphael nudged me on the arm and I glanced down at him to see his old and wizened face was covered in blood. "Jason, things are looking bad. Even with your clones helping out, Heaven is in terrible shape. At this rate, we're going to be slaughtered."

I nodded quietly, still feeling a buzzing in the back of my head. That telepathic attack was no joke. I keep hearing near-silent voices whispering, and it's starting to unnerve me. "I'll try and think of something. If we're lucky, I can-"

The female Founder interrupted me. "Ah, you must be the Hero that Satan whines about constantly. Enough with the chit chat over there, we've come to offer the angels and gods a... deal."

Zeus stood up to his full height, as did Gabriel, as our entire group eyed the two Volgrim that stood by themselves a few feet away from us. "A deal? We do not bargain with the enemy."

"You misunderstand. This is not a bargain. A bargain implies both parties get something of equal value. You will assuredly be the loser in this respect." The female Volgrim grinned a sharp-toothed grin, as her animalistic shark-like teeth splayed themselves across her face in a creepy manner.

Behind us, the council of generals that were having discussions, the war raged on as hundreds and thousands of enemy and ally combatants alike tore each other to shreds. I glared at the male Volgrim, though he could not actually see my eyes. "Are you threatening us? You think we will roll over and play dead? We're not giving you a damn thing."

The female chuckled quietly under her breath. "This is not a request. My people need this dimensional space to save our own kind. Our star is going to have a catastrophic sequence of events occur in less than five hundred orbital cycles. All of my people will die. We fight only to save our own kind."

I felt my body's tenseness loosen up, just slightly. "This is the first I've heard of this. Why are you telling us this?"

The female held one of her palms face up, as if it were a shrugging motion from their culture. "Simply put, we're telling you why we are conquering you. Resistance is futile. You can either perish here, or we will allow the angels and gods to flee down to the planet Earth. Life or death, it is your choice. Ah! But I forgot to mention..." She paused as her eyes flicked to the side for a moment, as did the male's, and then their vision returned to face us again. "In thirty more of your Earth-time seconds, our Dragoon corps will arrive, and when they do, you lose. We will exterminate you without fail."

I glanced back behind the Founders, towards the place where their soldiers seemed to be pouring from. Unless I was mistaken, that was a portal... a dimensional rift? Wait... does that mean...

Good god, why didn't I think of this sooner?

The female's eyes glanced at me for a second, just in time for me to realize she was attempting to read my thoughts. Since I had put universal nullification of telepathy on my body, she would find the effort fruitless. However, her complaint wouldn't matter. I had an idea.

In the blink of an eye, using my latent teleportation abilities a few times in a row, I popped away from the group and zipped forwards at an alarmingly fast rate, arriving directly in front of the portal where Volgrim kept pouring through and the last dregs of the demons were evacuating from. Seeing me, a few Volgrim that had just stepped through looked up in confusion.

"Ah! That's one of the Earthlings! Attack him!" A particularly brave soul quickly leaped into offensive mode. I didn't care though, he didn't pose an iota of danger to me. My visor shut in an instant as I aimed my mind at the portal. "**Seal.**"

The portal closed up instantly, as if it had never existed. Better yet, my seal meant it could not be reopened. They'd have to expend and waste more energy to reopen it again, being unable to reuse it.

Now then, the only thing left to do was to get rid of the undesirables.

As I had that thought, I suddenly felt a massive force grab me, lifting me up in the air, and smashing me into the ground. Of course, it didn't hurt me, but I was embedded quite deep into the... clouds? And the force kept pressing on me, as if it were a giant boot stomping me into the ground.

"ALERT: PILOT JASON, THE GRAVITATIONAL FORCE HAS BEEN INCREASED BY A FACTOR OF FIFTY IN YOUR IMMEDIATE VICINITY! SUIT DAMPENERS ARE UNABLE TO COMPENSATE! CRITICAL DAMPENER FAILURE IN FIVE SECONDS!"

Centurion blasted into my ear, scaring the bejeesus out of me. However, if it was just gravity...

" NEUTRALIZE! "

Yelling at the top of my lungs, the effect vanished and I leaped to my feet, whirling around to see the female Founder looking at me in confusion. How did she get over here so quickly?

"How did you-?! That technique should have ground you into pulp!"

She didn't hesitate to fire off another mind-bomb at me, though it had no effect this time. I felt a slight tingle in my skull as my neutralization ability batted away the mental attack effortlessly. It almost felt like a fly crawling around under my skull, a rather itchy feeling.

I grinned as I stared her down. "I just realized something. Satan played you for a fool."

She glared at me as ideas of how to combat me seemed to flood her mind. "I do not understand your species figures of speech, but I get the feeling you are speaking of betrayal. Why do you believe Satan betrayed us?"

"Simple. Satan faced me in combat, and he knows what my unique abilities are, yet he didn't tell you. Why do you suppose that is?"

The male Volgrim approached, staring at the spot where the portal once was. "Where is the portal? Why aren't the Dragoons here yet?"

The female gritted her teeth as she let out a faint hissing noise. She appeared to be quite distressed. "This human was just telling me that Satan has betrayed us, but he hasn't explained how or why yet."

"Come now, surely we aren't pretending to be naive." Raphael appeared nearby from out of nowhere, the other angels walking beside him. Zeus was nowhere to be seen. "You were planning to entrap Satan for your own gain, just as he was planning to entrap you. An alliance based on lies and deceit is one that will never stand the test of time."

"Raphael is right. Zeus is wiping out the Volgrim quickly, now that the demon generals are gone. Those weapons he gave you were only temporarily able to turn the tide of battle, but once

we figured out how they worked, it was easy to avoid them. The demons have millennia of combat experience against us. You have none." I smiled as I caught a glimpse of a Volgrim sneaking up behind me with a blaster. Jerking my hand back, I shot a wave of energy from my palm, originating from my Hypersuit, and shredded the Volgrim to bits. "The demons are a dangerous enemy because they have access to Thought Energy. You do not, therefore you are not. You cannot defeat the angels and gods without the help of the demons, but they are merely using you for their own gain."

The female gnashed her teeth harder as her glance shot from the male and back to me. "Unarin, what are we to do now that the portal has shut?"

The male shook his head slowly. "This is saddening. To think that twisted red-skinned creature would do this to us. Ah, well. We will lose a few million troops, but we will live to see another day."

Saying this, Unarin's eyes illuminated as I felt a tremendous amount of energy swirling above him. No- it had been there the whole time?! Thought energy?! But I thought the Volgrim didn't have access-?!

"You will win this round, Hero. Enjoy slaughtering my people, for this will be the last true victory I allow you."

A massive hole appeared in the sky as Unarin began to levitate upwards. The female glanced at him with fear in her eyes. "This is- just like the Fifth Great War! He is unleashing his power!"

Across the battlefield, a greenish gas began to appear, one which dissolved anything inside of it, skin, bone, and armor alike. Thousands of angels and Volgrim perished in an instant as the gas blasted outwards. Seeing the incoming massacre, angel and Volgrim alike began to flee away from it in opposite directions as terror filled their hearts.

Unarin rose into the sky, speaking just before he entered the massive hole. "Farewell, sister. Losing you will hurt my soul like nothing else ever could."

A moment later, he vanished. My mind spun, not just with the revelation that he was able to use thought magic, but that he possessed *so much* of it, dwarfing even Gabriel himself! I had no time to think those thoughts, however, as I dashed towards the gas. Already, my clones were leaping into action, trying to neutralize it. However, the more spells the used, the more potent it became and the faster it expanded, as it seemed to erupt from deep within the bowels of Hell up into Heaven.

"We can't stop this gas! Evacuate the angels! Open up portals to Earth, and close them before the gas can exit into Earth itself! We can't spare time for stragglers!" I shouted orders to my clones and projected a wide area telepathic message so all could hear me.

Heaven was vast, able to comfortably hold tens of billions of angels, but there were few buildings and most of Heaven was simply wide open spaces. Worse, it had a limit to how far one could run before they slammed into a strange invisible wall. The gas expanded in all cardinal directions at once, as angels fled for their lives, my clones opened portals to places all over Earth's deserts and arctic as rapidly as they could. The angels were immune to the heat and cold, and no humans would be able to see them there... hopefully. Anything was better than outright genocide.

The gas came closer and closer, as tens of millions, even billions of angels rapidly evacuated Heaven. Suddenly, Raphael *screamed* in horror! "Oh no! The spell! They will evaporate into thought energy if they step foot on Earth!"

I felt sick to my stomach as I realized what he meant. Billions had already evacuated, and all of them would surely have already died.

I started to say some, but Zeus interrupted me. "Calm down, Raphael! I released that spell earlier today when we discussed sending angels to Earth! Don't you remember?!" Charging forwards, Zeus stood right beside a portal as thousands of angels poured through the small hole into the barren Antarctica plains.

Glancing over my shoulder I felt my body shake as I realized the gas was seconds away. Leaping through the portal, I jerked my head back to wait until the very last second to close it.

Timing it carefully, I winced as I used my magic. "**SEAL!**"

As the portal closed, a hauntingly beautiful woman screamed for me to keep the portal open. But it was already too late. The portal closed, as she suffered a horrifying death.

I felt sick to my stomach and vomited on the ice, repeatedly, over and over, as I realized what had just happened.

Was Heaven... no more?

Part 274a:

It took me a moment to regain my composure, but my mental state was very traumatized.

The AI in my helmet kept giving off preliminary counts of survivors and those presumed deceased and it was starting to really irritate me, but I stuck with it. Fifteen billion angels and gods survived. Sixty billion died. The Volgrim numbers were far lower and were only preliminary estimates, but they ranged from ten million to a hundred million in either case.

At least, those were the current estimates, based on data shared by all of my Hypersuits in the local area. All of the portals had finally been sealed... and in the end we managed to save less than 1/5th of all the angels.

But that was only the beginning. Now, we eyed down another two or three million Volgrim that had also rushed through the portals to escape with their own lives. And despite how their commander had betrayed them, they felt no particular anger towards him. We were still enemies.

In our rush to escape, one of my clones had also managed to find the two demons I teleported to a safe space, they were bound by powerful word magic so as to not wake up. I'd have to speak with them later. For now though, the female Volgrim commander looked on quietly as her troops rallied behind her.

With the air between her troops and mine tense, as well as freezing cold, she spoke first.

"So this is it then. I will perish on an alien planet outnumbered a hundred, if not a thousand to one. Is this what you would prefer, human?"

I stared at her quietly. Frankly, I don't know what to do. Killing the Volgrim would be all too easy. Sending them back to Volgarius would mean we would likely end up facing all of them again anyway, in a situation where the circumstances were not quite so favorable. Taking them prisoner was an option, but that would mean a lot of space would be required, not to mention special facilities for some of them, due to their innate psionic powers. While few had those abilities, those that did would be far too much for a normal human prison to contain.

Haahh... killing them with a simple 'genocide' word would be simple. I could have done that at any point, to be honest, but that would be taking the easy way out. While guaranteeing myself a future free from them ruling the universe or whatever, it would also be an absolutely inexcusable and abominable thing to do. I certainly wouldn't want to do so here.

As I mentally scratched my head on how to proceed, one of my clones walked up to me. I couldn't help but notice that his manner of walking was... different from mine. Based on the black painted stripes on his suit, he was only a second generation clone, meaning he'd probably been alive a lot longer than many other ones, maybe he was even one I created initially way back in the day?

He ambled up beside me and leaned back against an icy cold outcropping, as he sighed casually. "Listen, Original, I've had this idea bobbing around in my head for a long time now. Frankly, this would be the best time to test it out."

I felt a quizzical expression pass over my face as my clone said this to me. "You have an idea? I'll take anything at this point." It was so odd to hear my clone thinking of something I possibly hadn't thought of yet, but if there were discrepancies with the clones immediately after their creation, surely those would only grow over a long period of time.

The clone's visor shut as his voice played in my helmet. I closed up my visor too, since frankly even with my suit's protection, the cold was very intense.

"Listen, we have the ability to change the fundamental laws of physics with our abilities, yet we rarely use those abilities. Why not create a prison in another dimension? Then we seal it up so only we have the ability to access it."

I felt stunned. It was such an obvious idea, but I had grown so used to my abilities, so lax over the years. I barely even used them anymore, but my clones were constantly on the frontlines fighting enemies that grew smarter to our tactics every day. They had likely developed all sorts of new skills and I hadn't once even asked for their thoughts.

It was so simple, yet elegant.

"That sounds like a solid idea, but what about the spiritual energy cost? Creating an entirely new dimensional space is probably going to take a lot of energy."

My clone shrugged lightly. "Yeah, I know. But hey, if all your clones just donate their energy to you for today, they'll regain it tomorrow anyway. Just do that and our combined energy should be enough. Each of us 'two-ers' is equivalent to, what, like a million humans or something? I'm just a second level, the 'first-ers' have more than me, literally twice as much."

I nodded slowly and started to say something, but he interrupted me. "Oh yeah, by the way, next time you go and drop Samantha somewhere unconscious, give us a warning, alright? I found her and some old demon sleeping in a corner, and Centurion explained what had happened. Not cool, dude. Do you even think about how your actions could affect the future? If she'd died... well, I don't think I have to explain what would happen."

He shrugged and wandered off nonchalantly. I felt a sudden rush of energy enter my mind as he sent it my way. Moments later, more energy flooded in, as other clones quickly began doing the same. Each gave about 95% of their energy, and in turn I felt absolutely unstoppable.

As my visor popped open, I realized two important things. First, the Volgrim were visibly shivering, and some were trembling violently. The angels and gods had a 'halo effect' that surrounded their bodies, and my clones and I had our hypersuits, but the Volgrim battle armor was wholly insufficient to deal with sub-zero temperatures. Even the female commander was shivering, though she tried to maintain a brave facade.

Secondly, I noticed that once again, she was attempting to probe my mind, but failing. I was about to inquire into why she kept trying when she spoke up.

"You know, something is very odd about you. I can tell that you are using magic, and that you've managed to block my telepathy. That in and of itself is quite interesting, yet I also sense that whenever you use your magic, your entire presence vanishes for a few moments while you cast the spell. The manner in which you cast is also different but-" She paused for a second as an especially strong tremor went up her spine, before she spoke again. "...b-but the fundamentals are the same as for the demons."

After she finished, I raised an eyebrow that she couldn't even see. "Well, as interesting as all of that was, I think we can all see that as badly outnumbered as you are, you're going to die quickly unless we can get you out of this arctic environment. Give me a moment, for I have a solution."

She opened her mouth to respond, then thought better of it.

As my visor slapped shut, I aimed my hand at a small empty spot about twenty feet in diameter a few dozen feet away. " **PORTAL! DIMENSION!** "

Running forwards, I jumped into the portal without hesitating. Every moment counted, and even for the enemy, we should not treat them like animals. We were better than that.

Suddenly, I found myself in a pitch black, absolutely empty space. It was like floating in outer space, but no stars were visible. I activated my suit's lighting, and could not even see my hand in front of me. I could only see the HUD inside my of my suit.

Location: UNKNOWN

Lifeforms: NONE

Biological matter: NONE

A series of readings came up. It confirmed what I thought... there was nothing here. Ah well, time to fix that. After closing up the portal behind myself, I began to work.

" **CREATE!** "

Frankly, I didn't know what to create, so I just imagined a flat space.

" **CREATE!** "

Then, I imagined light coming from above.

" **CREATE!** "

Followed up by the ability to project the light visibly.

It took me hours. I felt my energy draining noticeably each time I created something, but I began to see the effort pay off.

Finally I had done it. A recreation of an image I had seen in my childhood, an artist's representation of Heaven. Frankly, the idea of putting the Volgrim inside a dimensional space prison, unable to escape, soured in my mind. It would almost be like torturing them slowly.

So instead, I created a lavish paradise, one they wouldn't *want* to escape from. Though our enemies, the Volgrim were similar to humans in appearance, and killing them or imprisoning them seemed to me unethical. Perhaps with a bit of affection shown, this might plant the seeds for an alliance?

The dimension in front of me seemed almost planet-like in its appearance. Despite being only a few thousand miles in size, every inch of it was breathtaking. Fountains of water, trees, animals, lush green grass, a sun in the sky, and an entire fake expanse of stars to remind them of home. Naturally, I had used 'ecosystem' to fix in the smaller details, and I had Centurion correct me along the way with his library of information on Earth, so the micro-planet was modeled somewhat after Earth, but much prettier.

But... something about this bothered me, too. This seemed eerie. I have the ability to create new dimensions, new planets, and even a fully functioning star.

This is... exactly like the dimensions I observed in the labyrinth.

What if... no, I can't be thinking thoughts like that. That would be just stupid.

Reopening the portal, I jumped back through and was surprised to see an entire village had sprung up out of nowhere! A quick glance around revealed that my clones had created this village to keep the Volgrim warm and housed temporarily until I returned. Even with just 5% of their spiritual energy remaining, this was child's play.

Walking over to the female Volgrim, my visor popped open as I spoke.

"You know, we've been fighting for decades, and I think this is my chance to right some wrongs. I'd like to start by formally introducing myself. My name is Jason, and I hope to change

your opinion of my kind from enemy to ally."

She stared at me with her mouth pursed, as she considered my words. "I see. An admirable quest, I would say. My name is Dosena, second founder of Volgarius. The one you saw before was Unarin, our highest Founder. Do not call me an ally though, for I am no ally unless Unarin himself calls you one."

I nodded carefully. "I understand. I had originally intended to place your people inside of a prison, but in light of trying to extend goodwill, I had a change of heart. Please follow me, and bring your soldiers along."

She stood up from her seated position and nodded quietly, as the other Volgrim generals in the room glanced at each other and then stood up to follow.

Perhaps this will be seen as an important moment in the war. Perhaps this will be the change the future so desperately needs.

Only time will tell.

Part 275a: A Piece Of Peace

Dosena seemed quite impressed by what I had done. As she and her fellow Volgrim looked around, I could almost taste an intangible feeling of defeat that had changed into something more akin to acceptance.

"To be the loser in a battle, and then have the winner give us a 'prison' like this... you do realize we are enemies, correct?" Dosena glanced over at me from the corner of her eye as we stood side by side.

I nodded solemnly. "We are enemies, yes. But why? Why are we enemies? Why did we have to enter into this war? Don't you find it the least bit odd that we have been killing one another for half a century of my people's time, and not once have we ever sat down and simply *talked*? The only time I've ever successfully talked with a Volgrim without it coming to blows was during my first contact with that scout ship, all those years ago. What happened? Why did we become enemies after such an otherwise neutral discussion?"

Dosena paused as she mulled over my words. "Well, it's true that the discussion itself was banal at worst, but it was... the underlying events. Those are what caused the Volgrim to attack. That is all I will say regarding this matter, anything else is treason towards Unarin."

"Treason, huh? Treason... you know, your beloved leader, brother, commander, whoever he might be... he left you to die. He fully expected you to perish inside that gas, along with all of his fellow comrades. Don't you find that the least bit... disgusting?"

A small scuffle broke out among a Volgrim and a pseudo-angel, which caused them to get in an almost humorous fistfight, but the angel won the fight, decisively knocking out the Volgrim after just a minute. A small crowd of spectators had formed to watch the scuffle, but they dispersed when it ended so quickly. I decided not to interfere, sometimes it was best to let these matters work themselves out.

Dosena grimaced at me. "What do you know of Unarin? Nothing. He unified our people during the time of the Great Wars. After successfully dominating the battlefield with his incredible power, he forged a lasting peace by forcing all Volgarians to submit to mind wipes. None were exempt, save the Founders. But by wiping away our bloodied past, he was able to unify our people under one single banner, allowing us to forget old rivalries... as well as the existence of... well, that would be 'classified', in human-speak, I suppose."

I balked at what she said. "He *mind-wiped* all Volgarians?! My god... that's just... awful. That's something a dictator would do. I know you're fond of him, but can't you see just how

awful that is? He removed their free will, their choices they had made throughout their own life. In essence, he zombified his entire race!"

Dosena's grimace transformed into an outright scowl. "You think him being a dictator is a bad thing? What would you know? For every war the humans have had in their short existence, the Volgrim have had hundreds! Thanks to Unarin's actions, no matter how vile *you* might think them, our people were able to completely unify, creating a peace that has lasted hundreds of thousands of orbital cycles. While his actions might seem unethical to a primitive, they completed the goal, and prevented millions, even billions more from dying. Of course, humans are mortal, so they would die anyway... but if a Volgrim will live forever due to our biology, then losing one in a war or due to a random act of violence is an awful tragedy."

I decided to flip the script. "So the means justify the ends, then? For your talk of how holy and pious he is, he didn't hesitate to jump into a war with Earth. How many Volgrim have died because of this war now? A hundred million? More? Less? Where do you draw the line? And for being a peace loving race for millions of years or whatever, you still seem to have an awful lot of military technology. Seems to me like he's ready to pacify his entire population should they ever revolt."

Dosena's anger faltered. "Well, that is to say... he told you of our star, and how it would soon explode. Losing a few hundred million Volgrim is nothing. Soon, if we can't find a new home for our people, all of them will die. Only those able to survive by fleeing onto spaceships will survive, and the fuel and alloys needed are quite scarce on Volgarius. Especially since we spent a lot of material creating the- err, well, that's not important."

Dosena seemed to be hiding many secrets. Sometimes she would seem to bring up something important, then quickly bury it. My telepathy was unable to penetrate her fierce mental barriers, so I could only guess at what she was playing at.

"...Right. Still, it's interesting to learn more about your people. I hope you understand that I'm not the enemy you think I am, and perhaps we can come to a mutual understanding. You're still going to be imprisoned here, and I've put a seal on this place so nobody aside from myself can create a portal here, but you're in no danger of your resources running out or the planet dying. You'll be able to live comfortably here... and as for the rest of your people, perhaps I can use what you've told me to find a resolution so we can end this war."

Dosena turned and looked at me carefully. "That would be... pleasant. An end to the war would allow our people to return to doing what we were focused on before all of this happened. We simply wish to find a new home to live on... a place that will last us for hundreds of millions

more orbital cycles. If you could somehow find such a place, you would effectively be able to put an end to this war at a moment's notice."

I smiled at her, an expression I had not deemed any Volgrim worth seeing for decades. "I understand. I'll do whatever I can. Thank you, Dosenia."

"Thank you, too, 'Judicator'." The corner of her mouth for a second almost appeared to crack, as she seemed to stifle a tiny smile.

* * *

Next I went to where the other two prisoners were. Agares and Samantha. Or Belial, whatever she called herself in this time period.

Having been paralyzed by my clones, they were held in separate rooms. No need for them to be able to conspire with one another. One interesting thing I learned about Samantha from the future was that basically all demons require their mouths to form chants, and their hands to form signs in order to use magic. So by paralyzing their bodies but not their mouths, we were able to effectively stop both of them from using any magic, period.

Agares didn't interest me. I've spoken to him already, and while he might be useful for information, my mind has been ripping itself apart as I thought of Samantha and myself in the future. I don't know what I expected to talk about with her, but hopefully it wouldn't be a waste.

I walked into the room where she was being held. She was lying on top of a rather comfortable looking bed, complete with light, airy covers. Having been teleported to my underground base, it would be fairly simple for Satan to find her if he wanted to, and no doubt he would come looking soon, but I had every intention of letting her and Agares go free... after I'd spoken to her.

I walked in the room and immediately noticed her eyes were following me. She couldn't even move her head thanks to the total paralysis.

"Oh, excellent, another suited man. Just what the doctor ordered." She rolled her eyes and then looked away from me. I noticed that one of my clones had put her in a bathrobe. Knowing myself, he probably used word magic to pop her into it, so she wouldn't get the wrong idea.

"Sama- err, Belial. I've been wanting to speak with you for a long time. I'm sorry about the manner in which you're being held, but I thought this would be the only way I could get that passionate temper of yours in check for a short while."

She stared back at me again, her eyes narrowing slightly. "My temper, huh? We've barely even spoken. How do you know anything about me? Did we really fight in the future?"

I nodded slowly as I pulled up a wooden chair next to her bed and sat down, removing my helmet. She seemed shocked that I would reveal my face to her so easily, but I thought it just had to be done.

"Yes. In the future I come from, you and I, err, *clashed* several times, in a manner of speaking. I wouldn't call us enemies though."

"So what are we then? Friends? As if I'd ever be friends with a human." She blinked slowly as she spoke.

"Huh? You hate humans? I thought you were somewhat fond of humans. Maybe that changed at some point over the next hundred million years..." My voice trailed off as I realized I had just blurted something out, possibly that I shouldn't have even said.

"Fond of humans? You're an interesting one. Actually, I didn't say that I hated humans. Among demons, I'm probably one of the most moderate. I neither hate nor like them. I've known a few courageous humans, over the years. I was often given missions infiltrating your kind, to seduce emperors and constables and kings, so naturally I met more than most demons would, and I've had some... long conversations with them."

She glanced away again and I could swear for a second I saw her blush. "Actually, there was one man... one human... he wasn't really all that bad. But the stupid mortal went and got himself killed, so it's not like he..." She paused as she swallowed slowly. "Well, that doesn't matter now. Anyway, the fact you seem to know so much about me while I know so little about you is rather offputting. Wouldn't you agree I'm at a disadvantage here?"

I shrugged. "Yes, I suppose so. That can't be helped though. I'm trying to change some important things about the future, but I don't know if what I'm doing is wrong or right anymore. Then there's the matter of... things I would prefer to *not* change, but that can wait."

"So what are you trying to change then? What is it that you want to even do? Do you have a plan at all?" Her face now held an expression of curiosity. She appeared to be interested in what I was doing.

"I sort of have a plan, but it's... vague. When I announced my presence thirty-ish years ago, I told everyone that I had to prevent the destruction of Earth. It's the only thing that I know will happen. I know a relative timeline of when it will happen as well. That gives me a deadline and a goal. Aside from that, everything else is incidental."

"Well, that's certainly... a goal." She didn't seem very convinced but it certainly sounded crazy to even think of it. "So... do you know how the Earth is destroyed?"

I shook my head. "No."

"Do you know who is to blame for its destruction?"

"No. Probably the Volgrim, but I don't actually know for a fact." I shrugged, since I didn't get any precise information from OMEN. Damn, if only I had pressed him more carefully.

"So you don't know who is going to destroy the Earth, or how they will destroy it, but you know *when* they will destroy it. You know, that's not going to help you out very much."

Jeez, she didn't tear me apart like this in the future. She certainly had a way of breaking down my goals to make me feel foolish.

"I suppose not. But, then again, if I can get the Volgrim to become allies, or at least stop this war and sign a treaty, that's one group out of the picture. That would only leave the demons as culprits for the destruction of Earth."

She sneered at me, all of a sudden. "Oh *really*? Just the demons, huh? I've got news for you, the demons love Earth. Satan only has two goals himself, which are to destroy all angels and humans, and then to live on the Earth forever, or at least until the sun explodes or whatever. I can personally guarantee you that Satan would do anything in his power to prevent Earth's destruction. If anything, you should look at the angels and gods. Their greed is surely what will destroy this planet."

I shook my head carefully. "No... you're wrong on two things. For one thing, in the future I came from, the angels and gods no longer existed. They were almost entirely exterminated. Only one survived, and a few others were technically alive in special forms, but they were a shadow of their former selves. As for the second thing you're wrong about..."

I paused, as I realized what I was about to say might be a really, really bad thing to let slip... but I wasn't sure of the date it occurred, or the location, so it probably wasn't a huge slip to tell her...

"...well, let me just ask a hypothetical question. Can Satan protect the Earth if he is no longer among the living?"

Samantha's face stared at me blankly for a moment, and then slowly started to change into... a grin?

"Ha... haha... that's a good one. I know you're from the future and all, but if you were somehow fighting me, and I survived, but Satan didn't... well, it's a good joke. There's no way he could die. And if he did, I can assure you, I'd probably kill myself too. Many demons would. Without Satan, we simply would have no purpose."

I stared at her coldly, letting my eyes speak the truth. "Satan dies, some time in the future. You did not kill yourself. I don't know many other demons in the future, but at least a couple

other ones also did not. So... you're wrong."

Her expression changed to disbelief in an instant. "That's ridiculous. Have you been telling me nothing but lies this whole time? There isn't a being that could possibly kill Satan. He's developed countermeasures against every powerful foe he's met. Gabriel, Zeus, Raphael, none of the archangels could do it. Even against Unarin, the head of the Volgrim, Satan has crafted many careful countermeasures. Absolutely nobody has the power to kill him. And if they did, he'd surely know of them." I felt my gaze lower, as the thought of that *monster* appeared in my mind. "I don't know about that. Are you sure, absolutely sure... that nobody could defeat him?"

Her eyes flicked back and forth as she thought of every strong person possible, but she eventually brought her gaze back to me. "I'm positive. I can only maybe think of one who would stand a chance against Satan, but he vanished a long time ago. Presumably to the ether."

He?

I felt my inner thoughts digest that single word. A male? Of course I thought of Amelia, the one who had summoned Satan to best me in a battle once. Naturally, she had to have killed him in order to make him her puppet. But then again, since arriving on Earth... I hadn't thought to even once look for her. Was she even alive at this point? She was just a human. Maybe she hadn't been born yet. If I now possessed the white Orb, then the black one must have been out there somewhere, and as a child perhaps she found it, dropped in a battle by angels and demons, and she used its power unwillingly, becoming a cursed demon who roamed the land, searching for souls...

Or maybe I know nothing. Still, couldn't hurt to check. "One moment, please."

Turning away from Samantha, I walked out of the room and closed the door behind me, walking a ways down the hallway until I was well out of earshot of her room. Speaking to the air, I used my wordsmithing. " **Locate.** "

Immediately, my mind spread out across the universe, searching every nook and cranny for the one I sought. Quickly, it discovered her location! She was alive? And her location was in... Chicago? What the hell, she lives in a major metropolitan area?

I felt my heart pound as I thought of the implications of this discovery. Suddenly, I felt a presence watching me, not unlike when I had sought out Satan from aboard my ship.

A terrifying monstrous face appeared in my mind, as a dark dinosaur-like head hazily popped into my mind's eye.

" *Well then, looks like we have an intruder. And just who might you be?* "

I felt my body forcing itself to respond, but the signal was cut a moment later, as the dark presence shoved me away, cutting off the signal abruptly. What the hell?!

Part 276a:

I felt my entire body shaking slightly, as I reeled from the appearance of yet another dark presence in my mind.

When I 'died' during my battle with Satan, the curse mark lost its power on my face, though the scar persists. My clones, for some reason, never had the curse mark, so I was lucky to have it gone. Searching for presences of evil beings has proven to be very dangerous, not the simple thing I initially used to think it was. From now on, locating demons and dark gods will have to happen the hard way; intelligence and surveillance.

Making my way back down the hallway, I found myself leaning against the walls somewhat, as if my entire body was made of lead. Something about that presence... that voice... it was all too familiar, but it's been so long, I just couldn't place it.

Ah, well. I found myself returning to my simple-mindedness once again. *Best not to dwell on it too much.*

These things have a way of sorting themselves out.

Walking back into Belial's room, I felt my worries melt away as I saw her beautiful face once again. Then I noted her amused expression. "What's the matter? Did my beauty rile you up that much? Did you need to go take care of some *business*?" She winked at the last word and I felt myself blush slightly.

"No, there was something that I needed to confirm, and uh, well... I did."

She rolled her eyes. "Lighten up, it was a joke. Also, are you going to leave me paralyzed like this forever? Have you thought at all of how you're going to contain me in this prison?"

I shook my head. "No, to both questions. I'm not going to hold you here. I just wanted to have a talk with you, and we've talked. I confirmed many things, but I also had many questions bubble up as well. Containing you won't be a problem, since you and the grandpa can both go free."

She narrowed her eyes at me slightly. "Alright, that sounds nice. Why not let me go now, then? Do you have more questions that you want to ask, or is there something else that's bugging you?"

I shrugged. To be honest, I had many more questions. I needed to know what Satan was planning for the future. I needed to know if the Volgrim were still going to be allied with the

demons after this betrayal. I needed to get the answers to a lot of questions, but she wouldn't be much use in this, given that she didn't even know who Amelia was.

"I suppose there is, but that doesn't really matter right now." I turned away slowly to stare out the window, leaving my back to her. My mouthpiece closed in an instant as I activated my wordsmithing. " **Mobilize.** "

My mouthpiece jerked open silently as I turned around to her and sighed dramatically. "Hah, well, you're free to go then. If you would, feel free to grab your friend one room over, and I'll have you teleported out of here to wherever you want on Earth."

She blinked quickly as she rose up on the bed, draping her legs over the side. Instead of standing up though, she instead simply stared at me sulkily for a few moments. I was beginning to feel slightly unnerved but then she spoke up. "So that's it, hmm? And here I thought you'd want to spend a little more time with me."

I reached up to scratch my chin warily. "I don't follow..."

She waved her hand at me dismissively. "Oh come on now! I've known more than a few men in my day. You don't honestly think I can't tell you were interested in... something else? You're so careful to keep your distance, but a woman can tell when a man is lying. Or rather, when his body is lying. Isn't it time you were just a little bit more honest?"

I felt my cheeks flare up madly at what she was insinuating. She wasn't wrong, of course, but there's a difference between the her of today, and the her of one hundred million years in the future. How to put it? It's like her appearance was the same, but her personality, her entire persona, was just... *wrong*. Perhaps losing Satan changed her view on the universe, made her into a different person over the millennia. It just didn't feel right, as of now.

"In all honesty, we were an item in the future I came from. But that's a different time. Perhaps if the stars align themselves properly, that future will still come to pass. If they don't, if *we* don't, I won't forget those memories easily."

She nodded thoughtfully as she pursed her lips. Tapping her finger on her chin she stood up quietly. "Well, if that's the way you feel, I won't stop you. But if you ever change your mind... give me a call." Saying that, she pulled her hand behind her back, then forwards again, with a little card in her hand. "This is my 'business' card, just infuse it with a little magic and I'll get the memo. If you'd be so kind, please send Agares and myself to New York City. Anywhere will do."

I gently took the card from her hand, feeling her fingers touch my gloves. I felt like just letting her go was the wrong thing to do, but I decided to simply go along with it. "Sure... thanks, Belial. I'm glad we got to talk."

She nodded slowly as she pressed past me in the small room. "Sure thing. Give me a call sometime. I'll keep a line open just for you."

She slipped out the door into the hallway as I turned to follow her out.

This was not goodbye... only a temporary farewell. Yes, we would have to speak again soon.

Very soon.

* * *

"♪La la la, la la la!♪" Amelia sang a nonsensical but cheerful song as she hopped along down the street, wearing a cute blue summer dress she had taken from a local store recently. Of course, the other humans were getting smart nowadays with their cameras and whatnot, but she had no need for something as simple and transient as money, so she simply deleted files and blocked signals wherever she went. If a few people got in her way, it was always a good time for a snack!

As she sang, Leviathan, who had been dormant and silent for a few days, spoke up out of the blue. "Princess, I felt something invade my space. An intruder."

"Hmmm? You're awake, Levvy! I've been so bored without you to talk to!" She grinned cheerfully as she skipped down the streets of Chicago, happily glancing around the local ghetto to see if there was anyone that looked especially tasty on this fine day.

"Yes, I had decided to temporarily hibernate, thanks to the large disturbance I detected in the Thought Energy. A tremendous number of beings died, all at once. Tens of billions, and they didn't die on Earth either."

"Oh hmm? A lot of people died then? Well that's just too bad! Maybe if they weren't so weak and pathetic, they wouldn't die so easily, you know?" Amelia paused to glance at a store that had recently been vandalized. Its windows were shattered and the aisles were torn to pieces, but nobody was inside cleaning up. It looked to her like they had given up on fixing the mess entirely.

"My princess, not all can be as mighty as the two of us are. However, the one who invaded my space... he was not weak. He was strong. Based on the energy type, he was probably a Hero, too."

Amelia's cheerful grin evaporated instantly, as she stared into the hollow shell of the store with cold, unseeing eyes. "A Hero, you say? Ya know... it's been a long time since we saw one of those... wonder if this one is very strong?"

"Well, the last two we encountered didn't put up much of a fight. Princess, you can't go on holding a grudge like that forever. It's not healthy."

She shook her head slowly. "No... I suppose it isn't. But the way that brat... humiliated me..." Her lip trembled in rage as she thought of her very first encounter with a Hero. Some might have forgotten such a thing a long time ago, but Amelia had a long, excellent memory. She was not one to forget these things so easily.

"Yes, but don't you recall? Satan took him out, tore him to pieces. Surely you can let that go now?"

Amelia shook her head violently. "No no no! I won't forget it! I won't!" She stomped her foot on the ground in a huff of anger, the impact sending a slight tremor through the local area and a stiff wind blasting away from her. "That jerk beat me up and laughed about it! I won't rest until all the heroes are dead! And what about *you*, Levvy? When are you going to get your own revenge?"

The dragon sighed deeply inside her mind. "Ahh, princess... I've long since forgiven those grudges. In truth, it was never freedom that I sought, but simply a cure to my unending loneliness. Satan may have taken advantage of me, but he only did what was natural to all beings who are weak. He was merely seeking to improve his own chances of survival. Now that I have you, I don't need to-"

Amelia interrupted him with a huff. "Nonsense! You may have forgiven him, but I won't! That jerk kept my friend imprisoned! Amelia Greyheart never forgets a grudge!" She smiled a tight grin at the thought of revenge. She had been wronged many times, and in all but five cases, she had exacted revenge upon those who harmed her.

But, in time, she would get revenge. It was the one thing driving her forwards in this life.

She turned away from the store and stared up at the sky thoughtfully. "Ya know, I haven't paid much attention to things lately. Seems there's been lots of rocks falling from the sky, and people have been acting like there's bad stuff going on. Think there's another war coming?"

Leviathan tilted his scaled head down in her mind's eye, as he harumphed thoughtfully. "I'm sure there is. Humans and demons and angels are always fighting, whether each other or themselves. Perhaps we should find a newspaper to read, that might tell us what's going on."

Amelia nodded. "Good idea! First we find a newspaper, then we find the Hero! It's so simple!"

"Truly brilliant, princess. Let's get a move on, then. It's about time we got involved with the goings on of the world around us."

Part 277a:

I groaned as I slumped into my bed, back at my underground base. Taking off my helmet, I set it to the side as I flopped down face-first onto the comforting material. It was so soft... I just wanted to lie there with my face pressed against the white pillowcase and the cotton comforter and forget all my worries.

I don't know if any other people are having a worse week than me, but I can't imagine they are. Tens of billions of angels are dead, Amelia is alive, the Earth draws ever closer to its destruction, and my feet are killing me.

As I yawned, I struggled to right myself as I tried using my wordsmithing one more time. "**Inspect.**"

My mind traveled across the cosmos and the various dimensions that existed to arrive back at Heaven. The gas was still there, and appeared to be as pungent as ever. Now that I wasn't fleeing for my life, I could really take in and examine it to see how it worked. A long string of chemical processes appeared in my mind, using exotic forms of elements on the Periodic Table, elements that might not even exist normally were it not for the fact that Unarin had used magic to create this gas.

Uploading the data to Centurion for analysis, I yawned again as I felt my eyes starting to close. My mind was still heavy, but for a moment, I thought I saw a man standing in the gas. A man clad in chainmail, holding a long sword, with a blood red cape that draped from his shoulders down to the ground.

No, that couldn't be right. I could already feel myself drifting off to sleep. The man looked at me, his bright blue eyes offset by his matted down brown hair. He wore a crown, a simple crown that might have been a gold color, were it not for the fact that the tone was muted due to age and tarnishing.

The man turned to me and smiled. "Hello, Hero. I see you've finally come."

I blinked slowly. I'm dreaming, but he's still here? Now I stood in the gas, some distance away from him. The gas was having no effect on me. "Who are you?"

He shrugged as he turned his gaze from me, towards a crumbling structure in the far distance. "I'm just a man who has lived a long life. I died before I could fully realize my well-laid plans, but I suppose all men die before they are finished. Everyone dies with regrets."

I nodded slowly. "Yeah, that makes sense. Alexander the Great had plans to conquer the entire world, but he died too young, and never got to finish his quest. Many others before and after him died too early."

The man shook his head as he walked over and sat down on a rock, clasping his hands in front of himself. "Nay... it is not that men die too young, it's that a man's work is never done. One could have an eternity to live, and still their goals would pile on and increase, day in and day out. There is no end to a man's ambition and desire. All men die with regrets."

I swallowed slowly as I stared down at the sitting figure. "What is the point of life, then? Why do we strive so hard to fix things or to ruin things, if in the end our work is never done?"

He smiled faintly at my words. "A good question. How about we start with yourself, first. What are your plans?"

"Oh, that's *easy*." I let the last word lilt off my tongue sarcastically as I roll my eyes. "I merely want to prevent the destruction of Earth, save all humans, and prevent a massive extinction level event of the angels and gods. How hard can it be?"

He nodded sagely, apparently taking my words as literal. "A fine goal! Truly, few heroes have ever set their minds towards such a lofty purpose. But after you save the world, if you should be so lucky, what then? What task must you undertake in the coming days, months, years?"

I felt my eyes lower as I reached up and rubbed my chin. "Hmm... well, I don't know, exactly... I suppose if the war is ended, and we're allies with the Volgrim and the demons, then I've accomplished my goals and I just pick a new one based on how it all turns out."

His smile slowly dissipated as he replied. "I was like you once. A powerful hero, one who fought to give aid to my people. My goals were far less lofty than your own, but I would say I had my heart in the right place."

"So what happened? Did you save your people after all?"

He smacked his fist into his other hand's open palm. "Indeed! I crushed the Saxons and laid waste to those who opposed me! Then I rebuilt my kingdom and died of old age, with a beautiful wife at my side."

"It sounds like you accomplished all of your goals. Do you have regrets?"

"Yes..." His voice trailed off for a moment as he composed himself. "I had all of the power that I needed, yet my biggest regret is that I was too weak-willed to spread the goodness of my rule to all corners of the Earth. My people lived wealthy, luxurious lives, yet I did not try to spread that wealth among all the other peoples of the Earth. I believe I was lazy and slothful, in the end."

"You said you were a hero, but if you fought for your people, how could you consider yourself lazy at the same time?"

He pointed at me as he narrowed his eyes. "Because... with all of that power, I only sought to do the barest minimum needed. I was unstoppable on the battlefield, a tactical genius in the war room, and a monster in the bedroom, yet my conquests in all those areas were small and insignificant, and their effects would surely have gone to waste within a hundred years of my death."

I smiled at him as I cocked an eyebrow. "I see, so you aren't ashamed of your performance, but of the fact that the effects of your rule were short lived. You spent all that time building a kingdom, but if it were to crumble afterwards, then it wasn't sturdily built in the first place."

"You speak truth." The man stood up slowly as he stretched his arms in front of himself, then he dusted off his pants. "You know, I was probably the strongest Hero that ever lived. If I have regrets, I'm sure you will too, in time."

I nodded as I eyed him up and down. "The strongest, huh? You know, you never told me your name. I'm pretty used to talking to random strangers in my dreams but it gets old, after a while. Won't you humor me?"

He chuckled at my comment. "Amusing. You already know who I am, Jason. Take good care of Excalibur for me, lad. We'll talk again, soon. Oh, and try and actually train with the bloody thing once in a while... using your fists is a waste when you've got such a gem in your possession."

The man walked away from me, whistling as he walked. It reminded me of an old English tune I had heard, many years ago...

* * *

I stirred slowly, my eyes rumbling open as I fought my way back to reality. A quick glance at the wall monitor told me it was 8:04 AM. I had slept soundly through my 7 AM alarm.

It was a good snooze.

Sitting up slowly on my bed, I rubbed my eyes with my gloved hands, groaning that once again I had slept in my Hypersuit. I forget to take it off all the time, and I've practically grown used to living in it.

Aiming my mind at my body, I spoke a word. "**Clean.**" Instantly, my body felt as though I had taken a two hour shower. Not as good as the real thing, but certainly much quicker.

I heard a knock at my door. Using my wordsmithing, I deduced that it was one of the Hypersuit Commandos, though not one I recognized, and not one of my clones. Putting on my

helmet, I spoke. "Come in."

A woman walked in the door, her nameplate announcing her presence as 'Jane F. Lafayette'. Apparently she was from the French legion. "I hope I didn't disturb you. I have a report I need you to sign off for, regarding supplies in Cambodia."

I rolled my eyes, though she couldn't see them under my helmet. "Alright. I don't see why I have to sign this, but sure."

As I reached over and scrawled my signature on the paper, I noticed that her helmet was fully closed up. She was actually speaking to me through speakers added on to the sides of her cheeks. Handing the paper back to her, I decided to inquire. "Why don't you use the standard mouth cover for your suit? Don't you like fresh air?"

She shook her head as she took the papers back. "Sorry, commander, I wasn't sure if modifying the suits was allowed or not. I was fighting against the Volgrim in one particularly foul smelling area, so I devised a system in my off hours to transmit sound over speakers instead of having to open the suit up. Besides that, it was tactically inefficient to have to expose my face during combat to communicate with allies. If these suits are supposed to make us invincible, exposing myself seemed like a poor method of communication."

She paused as I almost could perceive embarrassment in her voice. "I could, err, just change it back, if it's not allowed..."

I shook my head quickly, as I stood up from my seated position on the bed. "Ah, no! That's fine. Please, keep up the good work, Lafayette."

She nodded as she brusquely saluted and left the room, leaving me to my own thoughts.

A speaker in the helmet? That was actually smart... I should get to work on that for my own purposes. Being able to hide my wordsmithing more easily would be one immediate way this would benefit me.

After creating myself some lunch with my powers, I walked out the door towards the intelligence branch of my underground base. I have some work to do.

Part 278a:

I remember when I was a kid, someone told me "Trust nobody, not even yourself."

It's kind of ironic, given my entire intelligence division is staffed entirely by my clones. Also, Harold's wife, Helen, she teleports down here occasionally. But generally speaking, this place is only for myself. Each clone is their own person, but they're all me, essentially, and we all understand our goal. I only keep the lowest level clones here, since there appears to be no degradation of their minds, only of their spiritual energy levels.

Naturally, one of the clones was assigned recently to monitor anything possible that might give us a lead on finding Amelia. A few of the other clones keep eyeballs on various radar systems around the world to watch for Satan, demon activity, and anything that might be relevant to the future, specifically.

The clone who has been monitoring for Amelia (I call him Jasolia, because it's amusing. He doesn't like the name, not that I can blame him) turns to me as I walk in. "Yo! Nothing to report of immediate concern, but I have been looking into some incidents that occurred in Paris a few years ago. Pretty gruesome... might be related, since the killer was never found."

I nod as he pulls up the files and sends them over to my visor feed.

Images of bodies that look like they were ripped to shreds appear in my visor. Some have unnaturally large bite marks taken out of them. That being said, in the future, Amelia ate a human whole right in front of me, so it seems unlikely she would leave parts behind.

"Official reports from the local news state these were likely caused by attacks from a roving gang of wild dogs. All the victims were killed in the night-time, in dark alleys, where they were likely to roam." Jasolia pulls up a heatmap of the areas hit.

I squint as I look at them. The attacks were all in a giant circle, all located around one central spot. If they were caused by wild dogs like the media said, then it would indicate their home was somewhere in that middle spot. But then again, I might say the same for Amelia too. I don't know if she simply likes the, err, taste of humans... or if she needs them for sustenance, or if at this point she needs them at all, but her horrifying eating habits are the only way I can think of to track her down.

"Yeah... I suppose it might just be wild dogs. But since I don't have anything better to do right now, I'll go and check it out."

Jasolia nods as he turns back to the computer. "Sure. I'll tell you if anything else comes up. Oh, and watch yourself, man. We both know what she is capable of."

"Yeah, you said it."

I turn and walk away from the clone intelligence center. None of the others had anything interesting to report or they'd be pestering me. Unlike in the future, when I was making clones all the time willy-nilly, I now keep a careful registry of when every new clone is made. Centurion helps with the records, allowing me to access the full list at any time I want. Right now there are about thirty level 2's, seventy level 3's, and the numbers get much bigger the further you go down the levels. I'd say I have about 2,000 clones in total currently, and could double that number overnight if I really needed to.

There's always a worry, deep in the back of my mind, that my clones will turn on me. I can't help it, I just feel the fear all the time. I've grown used to it, given there hasn't been an incident like the Hope incident in the last 20 years, but I just can't shake the feeling. Better safe than sorry, as they say.

I walk down the corridors to make one last stop in the Training Room, a heavily reinforced room that I use to practice my abilities or to train new Hypersuit Commandos. Today there are a few dozen flying around, beating the crap out of each other, and it's all good fun. Of course, my good friend Gregory is there, a demon who has helped me with intelligence on the demon community for a solid twenty years now.

"Gregory, I'm heading to Paris. Want any souvenirs?"

He chuckles as he keeps an eye on the proceedings. Naturally he's the training commander now, in charge of making sure all new recruits are up to snuff. "That's cute, since you and I both know 'souvenir' is a French word. You thought I wouldn't catch that?"

"Actually, it started off as Latin, but close enough."

He shrugs at me. "So, what do you need in Paris? Been a while since you were there."

"I need to find an... old friend of mine. Heard she might be around the area."

"Old friend?" He cocks an eyebrow. "You don't have 'old friends', unless you mean from after the start of the war or something. Or is she-" He pauses as a knowing smile spreads across his face. "Ahhh, I see. It's like *that* then, eh? I won't pry into your personal affairs."

I scowl. "No, idiot, it's *not* like that. She's a person of interest in a case I'm looking into. In any case, I need you to take over war operations until I get back. Probably will be a few days at most, but if you really need me, we both know I can get back here in an instant. Don't hesitate to call me."

"Mhm." Gregory stares at me thoughtfully for a few moments. "You know, word via the grapevine is that Satan's special lady was caught here and then let go. I think Satan wasn't too happy about that, but he was mostly mad that she was caught."

"Well, if he's mad at us, that doesn't exactly change anything. We're enemies, after all."

Gregory shakes his head. "No, I mean he was mad at *her*. She's supposed to be the second strongest of all demons. If she gets caught, it's a stain on the names of the demons in the highest echelons. Makes them think the humans are actually leading them into a trap. That's good news for you though, a bit of unrest means their war council won't be so eager to rush into a battle with us again. Hell, they're mad that you were able to rescue billions of angels, as well as yourself."

Gregory glances away from me for a moment, sniffing. "I mean, I'm not exactly happy about those angels being saved either. I don't exactly want their blood, but I'm not fond of them either."

I roll my eyes at his words. "Gregory, we're friends, but someday we have to do something about that... 'angelism' of yours."

He shrugs again. "Yeah, maybe. I dunno, I wasn't there for the Holy Wars, but I was alive for the Crusaders and the purges, the combined evil of humans, guided by angels and gods, didn't leave a good impression in my mind. You know, it's only an irrational fear if it doesn't harm you... but angels, from my perspective, are extremely harmful. I don't like them, and doubt I ever will."

I wanted to ask about the Crusades, but it seemed a tender subject for him, so I left it behind. "Fair enough. I'll try to keep your feelings in mind, next time. In any case, I'm off. Have fun running the show, boss."

Gregory nods as I turn and walk away. "Take care of yourself. Without you, I don't want to think of what all of us would be going through right now."

It's a feeling I'm all too used to hearing about.

Part 279a:

Paris... a beautiful city in the past, but one that has been reduced to rubble three times in the last fifty years.

Parisians have it hard. Even with the massive worldwide remodeling that took place, Parisians of all people were very fearful of technology after the nanobot hacking incident in 2027. They had the highest percentage of enhanced humans of any major city in the world, and it backfired horribly. Now they are among the lowest, with the government even banning human enhancements, to the chagrin of some 20% of their people.

I can't say I blame the government, though. Between debris from outer space, the entire population going serial-killer crazy for two straight days, and the Volgrim attacks, every cleanup effort has been halted halfway through and they're only finally managing to pull themselves together.

I walked down the streets of Paris, surveying the Eiffel Tower district. It's rebuilt now, and in decent shape. I can't see why they didn't make any improvements to it, perhaps turning it into a transmitter tower or a weather control platform. It's so odd that in the modern day world, there exists a major metropolitan city that leaves its weather to chance. They could always ask Versailles to alter Paris' weather, but it takes a lot more energy to use a remote tower than it does to use a local tower. HAARP proved that in the early 2000's.

After an hour or so, I arrive in the slums where the migrants tend to congregate. It's quite filthy here, with debris littered all over the streets, buildings that have become rickety as time went on, and the *smell* of the place is oftentimes vomit inducing. It smells like someone left a massive pile of bananas and other assorted fruits in the sun for too long. Occasionally I see children playing in the streets, but when they spot me, they run away quickly. Seems people aren't too keen on strangers in these parts.

Of course, I'm not wearing my Hypersuit right now. Instead, I'm wearing a plain brown leather jacket, with a pair of blue jeans and some black sneakers. I'm not exactly trying to fit in with the local population, but I certainly don't want people knowing a Hypersuit Commando is here. We're quite world famous and it would make investigations rather hard.

My face is disguised too. I took a mental image of a random police officer I found back in the states and copied his face onto mine, along with a few small alterations, just in case. Wouldn't want the guy getting fired for being spotted in a totally different country when he was supposed to be on the job! Facial recognition in security cameras is a nightmare these days.

Walking down the street, I quietly use my word magic to inspect various items and buildings. It's like having Sherlock Holmes powers, but without putting any effort into it. My innate telepathy is also sweeping the area, trying to let me find any clues that I can as to Amelia's whereabouts. I could just use 'locate' to find her, but I don't want that... *thing* knowing I'm looking.

Shuffling up to a ramshackle beaten up old auto repair shop, I happen to see a man inside, whirring away with a drill on a nice looking red Chevy, probably something from the 60's by the looks of it, though I'm not good with identifying cars. It's got a spoiler on the back, though I can't help but wonder what the heck purpose that serves.

I amble up to him and cough to announce my presence. The man stops drilling and glances at me. "Can I... help you?" No trace of a French accent. I detect a hint of a British or possibly Australian accent in his voice, though it's hard to tell from his first words. The guy has a protective face-mask on, likely because of the welding tools I spot on his far side.

"Yes, if you please. I'm trying to find a friend of mine. She lives in the area, black hair, looks like she's about age 12-15. Her name is Amelia. Know her?"

The guy stares at me for a long few moments before slowly turning his gaze back to the car as he continues drilling. "Look, I don't want no trouble, alright pal? If you're a cop and you're trying to catch me up for something, get lost. Your kind ain't welcome here."

"I'm just looking for a friend, that's all." I try the sincere approach, hoping it works.

The guy shakes his head slowly. "Sure you are. Looking around for some little girl... you creeps disgust me. There's a titty bar down the road, head east five blocks and you'll see it on the right. At least get your fix with a mature woman."

I blanch at his words. Come to think of it, my request *was* a little off in the head. I guess I can't blame him for jumping to wrong conclusions. "Uhh, I think you misunderstand, I'm not looking for anything... like that. She's my niece and I'm visiting from America. Please, if you could help me find out any idea of where she might live, I'll leave you alone."

The guy slowly rolls his eyes. "Christ. Thought she was your 'friend'? Now she's your niece, huh? There's an orphanage down the road, take a left on this street corner, head down two blocks, take a left, go another block, then take a right. It's called Hannah's Hope Heritage. Now piss off, fucking pedophile."

The guy angled his body away from me to put his back in my face. I saw him also reach down to his side as he placed his hand on a pistol. Best not to bother him any more. Smiling cheerfully, I say goodbye. "Thanks, sorry for bothering you."

"Get lost." Before he could pull the pistol, I beat a hasty retreat. It's not like the gun would hurt me in the slightest, but I didn't want to make a scene.

I walk away, gritting my teeth. Damn, I'm socially awkward, and that entire conversation could have gone so much worse than it already did. I need a new approach.

You know, I've never done very much questioning or interrogation. I don't know why this has never occurred to me, but with all my limitless powers, I've never tried to up my game in that department... hmm...

Some minutes later, I arrive at the orphanage the man spoke of. I knock on the door and a couple long minutes pass as nobody comes out. Just as I reach up to knock again, the door creaks open and an old woman peeks out. "What? What is it? Who are you?"

Her tone is almost accusatory in nature as her gaze moves up and down my body, squinting due to bad eyesight. "Uh, hello, my name is Steve Ackman, I'm looking to see if my niece lives here."

"Niece? You think one of these mongrels is yours? Ha! That's a good one." She glares at me but also laughs, and I'm not sure whether she's laughing *at* me, or laughing *with* me. Probably the former though.

"My niece is named Amelia. Is she living here?"

The old lady sneers at me. "Like I'd tell you! Hannah doesn't give away information to random strangers so easily!"

I frown at her remark. Hmm... this might be a good time to try something new.

Aiming my mind at her, I speak a single word. "**Truth.**"

She stares at me blankly and I try again. "Does a girl named Amelia live here?"

She stares at me blankly for another moment before shaking her head. "What a weirdo! I ain't telling you a thing! If you want to know about these kids, bring the adoption forms, or bring the police! Get out!"

Before I could respond, she slams the door on my face. Odd, she didn't say whether Amelia was there or not, and she acted as if my wordsmithing had no effect on her. I wonder what that means. Maybe 'Truth' isn't specific enough? Turning my mind to the inside of the house, my telepathy tells me there are fifteen kids inside, plus Hannah and an older man. None of the kids have any special mental barriers, and all of them seem normal. I don't think Amelia is here.

Pivoting on my heel, I sigh. This is going to be a long day.

Part 280a:

I knew this was going to happen. Damn my luck!

As I walked, I felt drops of water dripping downwards, as the sky bared its fangs at me, dumping a light torrential rain over my head. Fantastic. This is what happens when you live like mongrels in the middle of the 21st century and don't have weather control towers!

Standing under an open doorway as a massive blast of rain falls from the sky, I sigh in defeat. I've been at this for hours, and I haven't got the slightest whiff of her trail.

Glancing behind me to the doorway I had rushed under, I notice it's actually an antique shop of some sort. 'Will's Weird, Wacky, and Worn Heirlooms', huh? What's up with all these stupidly convoluted names? All the people around here act like they don't want to meet strangers, but then they name their buildings such weird names that you want to have a peek, just to see if the carpet matches the drapes.

Pausing hesitantly, I finally gather the courage to step inside. The place is dimly lit, apparently by old incandescent bulbs from the early 2000's. Man, talk about living like a caveman in a modern city. They must really hate technology.

"H-hello?" I almost cough as I speak, the dust is so thick in the air here. Everything is covered in it, clearly not a place that people visit very often.

Walking around, I glance here and there at all the... *crap* that's littered about. I dunno, 'antique' just isn't a word you throw around. Valuable china pots are antique, things created in limited quantities are antique... but random pots and pans are decidedly *not* antique. I spot a Mickey Mouse mug with a chipped bottom piece, with a hole you could stick a straw through. Too bad, that might actually be valuable were it not for the functional and cosmetic damage.

Walking past an entire wall of grandfather clocks (I don't know why, but every antique shop always has clocks for some reason), my nose begins to detect a whiff of... something. It smells like iron, maybe? Someone certainly has not been cleaning up around here in a long time. It's probably rust or maybe rotted food.

As I sneak my way past all manner of other assorted junk, including a bunch of fake jewelry, I wrinkle my nose as the smell becomes stronger. There's a door closed to the back room. "Employees Only", it says. Employees? Plural? More than one person ever worked here?

I knock hesitantly at the door, but nobody answers. Waiting for several long seconds, my stomach is twisting in knots. I'm undoubtedly breaking several laws by being here right now,

and opening this door adds several more. Oh well, are they really going to prosecute the savior of humanity for a little crime like trespassing, or breaking and entering? Get real.

I reach for the door handle and rotate it, but it just spins forever in my hand. Seems to be broken. Huh. Pushing on it lightly, the door loudly creaks open, which makes the otherwise silent room aside from the pitter-pattering of rain feel even creepier than it did before.

As the door opens, a wave of nauseating smells slams into me, blasting from out of the room as I detect a quiet but definitely audible buzzing noise. My eyes squeeze shut as the smell smashes into me, but I quickly use my wordsmithing, not giving a damn if anyone hears. "

Purify! "

Instantly the smell vanishes, but the memory of it lingers in my mind... and my mouth.

Finally I open my eyes and almost yelp in horror. There's a body in the room, and an old man. I shouldn't say 'body', as it's more like... large chunks of him... thrown all over the place. It's like if a massive crocodile grabbed hold of someone and shook them around so violently that pieces ripped off and went flying. Actually, that's *exactly* what it looks like. What the hell is this?!

" Inspect. "

An array of data enters my mind. Well, this is Will, the guy who ran this place. Analysis shows that he died at the ripe old age of 85 years old. But his body has been decomposing in this room for... five entire months?! Disgusting.

His body is melted into the ground in several places, and the entire room is covered in rust-colored blood. Whatever killed him, it certainly had his way.

Then, I glance more carefully at the data. It seems there are... traces of magic? Whatever killed him, it used demonic magic of a sort. So... it was probably a demon... or worse. "**Killer?** "

Speaking a question into the wind, I decide to ask the wordsmithing gods, assuming they exist. If it doesn't work, no harm in trying.

It works.

An image of the killer's face appears in my mind. That is, without a doubt, Amelia. She was here. She did this.

It's hard to believe that I found this murder on my first day of being here in Paris, but this place was out of the way. Were it not for the rain, I probably wouldn't have even stopped in here to look around. Seems nobody else did, either. I wonder if there are any other bodies in these slums like this? Are there others the police haven't found?

Walking back outside, I use wordsmithing to clean up evidence of myself being here. After phoning in the crime to the local police, I quickly leave the premises so they can come in and clean up. I wonder if the old guy had any family or friends? If he did, they'd be horrified to see what happened to him.

It's just... unforgivable. If Amelia really did do this, then she's every bit the monster I knew in the future. Just how long has she lived? How strong is she? How *evil* is she?

I need to find her and speak to her.

* * *

Harold pops into my mind later that night, as I'm staying in a nice 3-star hotel on the west side of Paris. I'd prefer a five star, but I don't want to attract any attention, and three stars are plenty comfortable for one night.

"Yo, kid! How are ya holdin' up?"

I shrug slightly, as I ponder the question. "Not sure. I found a body today... some poor old codger was offed by the girl I'm looking for."

Harold nods slowly. "Mmm. Mmm. Yeap, you gotta watch out fer them gold diggers! I tell ya what, you find yourself a nice wife like mah Helen, you'll be one lucky man! Anyways, I was jes' callin' ya up to let ya know that Beatrix called and wanted to talk to ya about help with the moon-base expansion project. If ya can give her a call, I'm sure she'd appreciate it."

I smile at him. "Sure thing, Harold. How are you and Helen doing? Enjoying the time together?"

"Yeap, as always, we're doing what we do best; spendin' lots o' time with each other to talk about life and the universe. You know how it is. And if ya don't know, well, maybe someday ya will!"

I nod quietly as we say our goodbyes. As Harold signs off, I'm left with the thought that he brought up... I miss Cassiel, and seeing Samantha ripped my heart in half. To think that she's with an enemy of mine doesn't make me feel very good. I just want to say 'screw the timeline' and whisk her away, but she's far too attached to him. Then, if I kill Satan, she'll surely blame and hate me forever for it. Then again, maybe she'd get turned on or something... women are complicated, especially when they're Succubi.

Oh well. It's sleep time. I'll just have to think about it in the morning.

As I climb into bed and immediately feel the effects of sleep grabbing hold of me, I once again hear a familiar voice speaking to me... one that sounds like...

* * *

"Look at that. You're back for round two." A familiar man stands in the distance, a sword held firmly in his hand, his body garbed in chainmail, as he wears a crown I've seen before, in a previous dream.

As he takes a swing at the tree, I note that the blade chops cleanly a few inches into the trunk and swipes through as if it were made of paper. "Your name is Arthur, right? King of the Britons?"

He rolls his eyes as he stabs at the tree, pulling the sword out a split second later with little effort. "You're a smart cookie. You know, I entered your mind years ago when you first took Excalibur from Lady Brittania, yet you never once thought to talk to me. Yet here you are again."

I shrug as I walk closer to him. I can't help but notice the sword he's swinging around is none other than Excalibur itself. "I dunno. I didn't exactly *want* to speak with you, it just kind of happened the first time. And now this time too, I guess."

He returned the shrug as he sheathed his sword and turned to face me. "Well, you're here now. That's what matters. Have you come to seek my counsel on how to properly wield this mighty, legendary blade?"

I stare at him for a moment with my mouth going slightly slack before I finally respond. "Uhh, no... not exactly. I didn't have any questions for you at all, to be honest."

"Oh. I... see." Arthur returns the dumbfounded stare as he quickly turns away and walks over to the tree, laying his back against it. "W-well, I mean, since you're here, I suppose if you err, wanted to... you know, if that was a thing you wanted to do... I could maybe show you how to use it...?"

His cheeks flared up a little and I realized that he was feeling embarrassed. Of course, he was a legendary hero whose exploits were told in children's tales, and if he was a literal Hero, then it's possible his legends were actually *weakened* over time, since most probably thought they were just silly children's stories blown up to sound exciting.

"Actually, rather than that, how about we discuss your life? I'd like to know more about you and your exploits as a Hero." Deciding not to let the moment go to waste, I felt the need to pry into his personal life. If he told me 'no' then no big deal, sword training would be nice too.

"Well... I mean, if you've heard the stories, you've heard all you need to know." Arthur held his palms out with the flats facing up to show there wasn't much to talk about. "I slayed the Saxons, built a kingdom, killed a hundred million demons, and married a queen from a Roman country. No big deal I guess."

"You killed a hundred million demons?" There was a small grin plastered on his face, but it disappeared when I brought that up.

"Well... yes. Probably more, actually. It was hard to count accurately, considering their bodies were totally obliterated in an instant. However, to say that it was a total rout would be... inaccurate."

He shuffled uneasily as he spoke. Something about this seemed like it was less of an epic conquest and more of a major mistake he deeply regretted. "I mean, I don't know much about you, Jason, only what you've seen when you grasp Excalibur firmly in your hands, but even you know a little about Excalibur's signature power."

I nod slowly. "The beam of light? The one that I used to destroy a Volgrim Battlecruiser with?"

He nodded quietly. "Yes... that's the one. But the thing is, that beam of light is a double edged sword, literally. I should preface this by informing you once more that I was, by far, the most powerful Hero who ever lived, at least in terms of raw spiritual energy."

I cock an eyebrow. "Really? The most powerful by sheer quantity then? Just how much exactly did you have?"

He chuckles a little bit. "That's amusing. I still *have* that energy. I'm not actually dead, Jason. I never died."

"What? But you told me you died an old man on your bed. How could I have the Hero's power if you didn't die and pass it on to the next in line?" I was dumbfounded. It would certainly make sense that he wasn't actually dead, given that I was speaking to him now. But... how was it possible?

"That's the thing, Jason. I still am the most powerful Hero. Far stronger than even you, as you are now. My Heroic gift given to me was monstrous levels of energy, the ability to detect energy, and the ability to predict energy. Combined with Excalibur's ability to fire off blasts of its wielder's energy, as well as healing them if they died, I was beyond unstoppable when it came to combat. Beyond that, I was forced into a circumstance later on in life that prevented me from continuing to live normally. Since I was going to die, I simply gave up the actual presence of the Heroic Aura, and it passed on to the next one when I sealed my soul inside of Excalibur, leaving it to Lady Britannia to keep hold of. In the wrong hands, Excalibur could destroy the entire planet. It is no child's toy."

His long speech left me with many questions, but already I was filled with wonder. "So, then, if you're here in this sword, I bet I could just manifest you physically outside of it! I can already think of the words required! You would surely be helpful to have as an ally against the Volg-

Arthur cut me off with a vicious glare, causing me to stop mid-sentence. "I think not, Jason. Don't ever presume to take my life into your own hands. I do not deserve to be out there, in the physical world. After... after what I did... I..."

Arthur paused for a moment as tears welled up in his eyes. Turning his head away so I couldn't see, he wiped them away quickly. His voice was choked when he finally regained his composure a moment later. "...All that power... and in the end, I was no Hero. I killed them all, you know. Not just the demons, but the humans too. Excalibur's blast leveled an entire mountain, causing a landslide that killed 100,000 humans. And in the end, they still called me a hero. Wrote stories, and plays about me... just... rubbish. Garbage. I don't deserve the title."

He bit his lip bitterly as he gazed off into the distance. I stayed silent for a few moments to allow him to clear his mind, before I replied. "I understand. I... I didn't realize something like that had happened."

"Yeah... nobody saw it coming. The power of the Hero had been growing exponentially, and after what happened with me, the Gods decided to severely limit it for future generations, for fear it would grow out of control. The Heroic Aura manifests itself the most in times of need, you know. If I've learned anything from my life... it's that there are no heroes and villains, only greedy people on one side or another looking to save their own skin, serve their own interests."

I paused thoughtfully as he spoke. "So, if that's the case, what about my powers? I don't know what powers many past heroes had, but mine seem especially strong and useful, almost overpowered to a certain extent."

He shrugged. "I'm not sure what your abilities are. I only know what I've seen when you held Excalibur in your hands. You'll have to explain your abilities to me first."

I hesitated, given that I didn't know if I could trust him with the information or not. Finally, I decided to simply explain it.

A few minutes later, he nodded thoughtfully. "Wordsmithing, hm? Yes, that does sound especially useful. Certainly more robust than previous heroes, including myself. The ability to create and heal, in my opinion, is far more important than the ability to kill and maim. With this power, you could do real good to help the world, even the universe."

I snicker slightly. "So, what, I'm like a god, right? This power is pretty ridiculous, right?"

He sighed slowly. "Well... perhaps it is. Frankly, I see too many openings to even consider it good. For one thing, if your mouth is ever maimed, your powers are useless. If someone silences you, they're useless. If someone sucks the air out of your body, they're useless. If you get dunked underwater, they're useless. It's certainly a useful ability, but it's not impregnable. Not to mention your body is quite frail. Against a demon, like Diablo, or Bael, or Satan, they would

crush you into pulp with one punch. And, as you said, they have ways of shielding themselves from your kill-words. Don't get a big head when you're easily destroyed by such powerful adversaries. Even Satan was... too much for me."

"Satan is strong, but he's not the one I'm worried about. It's Amelia who I'm having trouble with."

I toss her name out nonchalantly, but Arthur's face changes in an instant, as a look of total horror spreads over his face. "T-that name... what was that name again?"

I raise an eyebrow at him, noting his posture has changed and he now stands defensively, as if to prepare for an attack from an unseen foe. "Uh... Amelia. She's really tough. I only managed to kill her in the future thanks to the help from a dear friend of mine."

He swallowed carefully and collected himself with a single, long deep breath. "You can only be referring to Amelia Greyheart. I will not forget that name for as long as I live. I discovered her identity in some old Roman records when I defended a village on the Egyptian coast to kill some raiding Saxons. After that, she *came* to me in Camelot, and announced her presence. She somehow evaded all of my best security like it was nothing, something even the demons couldn't do."

He paused quietly as he wiped his forehead with his hand. "...Suffice to say, I did not kill her. She was monstrous. She broke my body down in ways that would horrify you, and she left me to die in my own land. I only survived thanks to Excalibur's healing powers, something she luckily did not take notice of. I would advise staying far, far away from her."

The terror on his face was palpable. I licked my dried lips carefully as I felt my own throat was cracking. "I believe it. However, this is non-negotiable. She is brutally killing innocent people, in horrifying ways. Devouring their bodies. I can't let her continue to terrorize the world from the shadows. Even the demons don't seem to know about her."

Arthur nodded quietly. "Yes, and it needs to stay that way. Trust me, Jason, if you chase after her, only agony and torture await. She will kill you in the most gruesome manner possible. She will maim you so badly that even in the afterlife the nightmares will haunt you. Don't make the same mistake I did. If you see her... *flee*."

I nodded quietly, as I noticed that the world around me seemed to be fading.

"Well, seems our time is up. Perhaps we'll talk again in the near future. Make sure you show up, Jason, or you won't get to learn about Excalibur's secret abilities." Arthur smiled a friendly grin as he wandered away from me, the world dissolving into a veil of light...

Part 281a:

My eyes blink open slowly as I feel my body is chilled to the touch. The hotel room is so cold that I just want to huddle up and stay under the covers forever.

As I blink my eyes, I decide to warm the place up with a quick word spell. " **War-** "

"So you're awake." A voice speaks out right as I start to wordsmith and my mouth snaps shut as I flip my head reflexively over towards the source of the voice.

A little girl sits over on the other side of the room, wearing a bright and cheerful blue summer dress. She's leaning one arm on a table right next to her, her face set into her palm. "Jeez, you slept so soundly you didn't even hear me come in. Some Hero you are."

My face blanches as I instantly realize... she's Amelia. I was expecting her to be wearing that odd gothic lolita dress she usually wore when I knew her, but maybe that was just a fashion choice she picked up in the future. Sitting up slowly in the bed, I carefully rotate from my facedown position until I'm facing her straight on, while still sitting in the bed calmly.

"Amelia. So you came." Keeping my voice even, my heart pounds rapidly as I realize I'm not wearing my hypersuit. It's not something that can be thrown on in an instant either, considering the speed I've seen her move at, three seconds to summon it with wordsmithing and then wordsmith it onto my body is two seconds too long.

Her eyes light up slightly and she sits up straight in the chair. "Oh? You know my name? You know, it's not polite to stalk a girl, might even give her the wrong idea."

She eyes me up and down, my powerful and tall masculine figure the exact opposite of her fragile and small appearance. Of course, appearances could be deceiving. If what I've heard is true, she's supposed to be even more powerful now than she was in the future. Satan from the future confirmed that.

"I've been looking for you. I wanted to talk. How did you know I was here... or that I was looking for you?"

My heart is pounding so hard I could almost swear she was able to hear it. She shrugs in response. "Anytime I leave a mess behind, I leave a souvenir to let me know if anyone comes looking. I always want to know if people remember me. What's curious though, is that I have no idea who you are, but you even know my name."

I can't help but notice that the way she's speaking is different from her super cheerful personality in the future. Is she always like this now? Why is she so different from how I knew

her in the future? She wears different clothes, doesn't have the black orb, and acts differently... yet she's every bit the brutal murdering monster from when I last saw her, if the wordsmithing gods were correct when they revealed her face to me.

I stared at her for a moment before replying. "Do you watch TV or read newspapers?"

She rolled her eyes. "Yes, I think he's mocking me." She appeared to speak to someone, but there was nobody else in the room. "I don't do either of those things, but if you think that implying I'm stupid will fly, think again!" She sneered at me and I felt my head pull back reflexively.

Something about her seemed... off. That might sound odd, given she was a massive genocidal serial killer, but she just didn't seem like the Amelia I knew.

"I, ah, I don't think you're stupid. It's just that I'm a very well known person in the world. I'm from the future. I time traveled back in time to change the flow of time."

It wasn't true, exactly, since I didn't intend to travel back this far and had no idea what I was doing when it came to changing the past, but it sounded reasonable enough.

Amelia didn't laugh at me, or snicker, she just... stared blankly. "Right... the future. Alright, so if you're from the future, and you know my name... then...?" She trailed off as her voice left an unspoken question hanging in the air.

I paused as I wasn't sure how to continue, but I decided to wing it. "Well, see, in the future I come from, you and I are friends. I've been looking for you to meet up with you."

She stared at me for a good few moments before a tiny smile crept onto her face. "Heh... hehe... friends... hahaha.... HAHA... HAHAHA!!!" She burst into a maniacal fit of laughter as she stumbled forwards and fell off the chair, rolling around on the ground, her calm composure and oddly normal manner of speaking totally gone now. This was more like what I was expecting. After a few moments, she calmed down a little bit and stumbled to her feet, grabbing hold of the chair to pull herself up, but she accidentally crushed it in her hands and fell back down. It didn't seem to bother her.

"Ha... haha... oh jeez, what a great joke! Me, a friend with a Hero! Haha, every generation the heroes get dumber and dumber!" She wiped tears of laughter from her eyes as she stood up and faced me. I quickly rose out of bed and stood up to my full height. Wearing only a small polo shirt and some sweat pants for sleeping in, I felt very naked in the face of her power. I was only seconds away from a swift and sure death, my only solace being that my clones would live on to change the future.

"Boy, it's like he thinks trickery and lies will get me to lower my guard. It's cute, really." Amelia once again seemed to be speaking to someone else, but there was nobody else in the room. I resisted the urge to raise an eyebrow, as I didn't want to piss her off and lose my head.

"I'm not lying. We were friends. I even know that you eat people to gain spiritual energy. I don't know a lot of personal details about you, because you were always so guarded when it came to your past, but I know that while you may do bad things, you're a good girl at heart."

I lied at the end, but telling her, as a Hero, that I knew she was outright evil would make the friendship thing even more of a stretch.

Her smile dissipated as she stared at me coldly. "Yes, he's surely lying. You think I should just do it already?"

I felt my teeth starting to chatter. Not because of the cold room, which was odd enough given this was only August, but because of the malice I could almost tangibly feel flowing from her body. Every fiber in my being screamed at me. *Escape. Escape. Escape.*

I resisted the urge to move my eyes around the room, keeping them firmly locked on her as I put on a false model of bravado. Mentally sending a message to Harold, I quickly told him to keep an eye on me and if she made any sudden moves to get me out of here.

"Amelia, you might not believe me, but you are my friend. I need your help now. I need you to help me put an end to this war that's going on."

Her eyes seemed to shimmer for a moment as her posture relaxed. "Oh, brother. Now you're begging me to help you? You're one of the most pitiful heroes yet. The only thing I can tangibly say is you have quite a bit of energy stored up, but it's really not even all that much. They just don't make 'em like they used to."

She rolled her eyes again. "Yes, I know, he might be hiding some awesome unique ability, but they all have one of those. Never works." Turning back to me, she shrugged again. "I haven't had a fun fight in a long time! I'm going to tear you apart right now. If you can lay one punch to my face, I'll listen! If we really are friends in the future, have no reservations! Just because I'm a girl doesn't mean you can't hit me? Okay?"

I started to respond but at that moment her feet pressed into the ground. "Alright, ready or not, here I come!"

Instantly, I made a split second decision and teleported to the roof with my innate teleportation abilities. My spherical vision detected a massive explosion under me as she swung at empty air, smashing through the wall behind me where I had just been standing. Holy shit!

As she swung and missed, her head jerked upwards at an unnatural angle as she had already detected my presence five stories above, on the top of the hotel. *No time to lose!* My adrenaline was racing as I quickly used my wordsmithing. " **Summon! Hypersuit! Wear!** "

Quickly, in the space of three seconds, my suit appeared and slapped onto my body as my helmet cover closed. Good, now she wouldn't be able to see me using wordsmithing. Two seconds after I donned the suit, the ground beneath me shook as she burst up through the roof, a titanic smile spread across her face as a wicked look took hold of her eyes. "There you are!! Let's play a game!"

She paused for a moment as I saw an unexpected moment of hesitation take hold. "Hm? What's this? He's wearing something different? How did he change clothes so quickly? And what is that thing? Why can't I sense his heroic aura anymore?"

Her eyes narrowed as she glared at me, the smile gone. "So this is your heroic ability, huh? Some sort of special armor, by the looks of it. Well, no armor can withstand my attacks!"

She charged at me suddenly, a bit of hop in her step as I watched her body move so quickly she appeared to phase into two beings. Which one was the real one- too late!

She appeared behind me, slapping me with the flat of her hand. I was braced for an impact from the front and totally unprepared for a rear flank. Smashing me downwards, I crashed through two levels of the hotel, falling ungracefully flat on my face in some random person's room. A man jumped in surprise when he saw me quickly stand up.

"Hide!" I yelled at him as my visor opened for a split moment before it shut again. I needed to get those new speakers, and quickly. Teleporting back up to the surface, I appeared right in front of Amelia, my fist already in motion. Swinging right at her face, I hit her with all my strength, sending her flying backwards and off the roof of the hotel into a small park behind the place below.

Teleporting down to where her body had landed, I jerked my head back in confusion. Instead of her, there was a small child-sized mannequin lying crumpled in a heap, its body wearing the exact same blue summer dress she had been wearing.

"Substitution, idiot." Her voice came from my side as I jerked my head over towards her. She shook her head slowly. "Sad! You don't even know the basics of my magic! I mean I do have literally hundreds of spells I could use, but REALLY? If you were my friend, why didn't you know I'd use that? What a liar! Still, I'll give you credit. You took that punch like a champ!"

I grimaced at her. She really was a lot stronger in this time than she was in the future. She rubbed her fist slightly, as she eyed me up and down. "That armor is a lot harder than it looks. I guess I'll just have to keep punching until it breaks!"

She giggled madly as she charged at me again.

Part 282a: Sparring

Amelia punches me so hard I can almost feel it through my suit's dampeners. Damned impressive, when you consider this suit should be powerful enough to protect the occupant from a supernova at point blank range.

"Amelia, stop! I don't want to fight you, this isn't how friends treat each other!" I implore for her to stop but she just punches me again, this one knocking me back just a little bit further.

"PILOT JASON HIRO, SUIT INTEGRITY IS AT 95%. CHEST INTEGRITY IS DOWN TO 76% AND-"

Centurion is cut off as another punch knocks me flat on my back. "CORRECTION, CHEST INTEGRITY IS AT 72% AND DROPPING!"

Great, the suit has a sense of humor. Amelia grins widely as she pauses to laugh at me sitting on the ground. "Wow, you're the first Hero to ever take my punches so easily! Most of the other ones died or got splooshed by the third one! But you're a terrible fighter, one of the worst."

She starts to say something else, but then a look of irritation passes over her face. "Yes, I know, alright? Calm down, Levvy, I can just heal my hands up later. Stop being so overprotective."

Once again, she seems to be speaking to someone I can't see. Was it the *thing* that spoke to me when I first accidentally entered her mind? What the heck is a Levvy, anyway?

Jumping up to my feet, I pop my visor open as I scowl at her. "If you won't listen to reason, I'm going to get serious now. I nearly killed Satan, and I can do the same to you, too."

This wasn't a lie. I had gotten a good grasp on her strength. She was maybe the same level or a bit stronger, physically, than Samantha. Her energy levels were also much higher than mine, and seemed to come from a terrible dark source I couldn't quite identify, but she fought fairly straight-forwardly, and her worst quality was her arrogance. She thought she was invincible and that I was a simpleton. She didn't even know what my abilities were yet, nor what my suit could do. It would be close, but I had a feeling that I could incapacitate her fairly easily, even without using my wordsmithing. It just wasn't my goal, and I wanted to avoid it if possible.

She glared at me as I spoke. "You're so full of it! I'll tell you what, give it your best shot! I'm not being serious, either! I'm just having fun!"

Saying that, she quickly made some hand gestures and I felt a disturbing amount of energy leave her body, as... she... what the heck?!

A shadow appeared to her side, a humanoid form, totally encased in blackness. It almost looked like something I had seen before, but it was hard to tell.

"Let's see how you deal with two on one!" Amelia didn't even give me a moment to respond as she rushed at me, reaching down and grabbing my ankle in the blink of an eye to yank me off my feet. The shadow behind her began to make various hand motions as I realized that most of her former spiritual energy was condensed inside of it. It was almost as if she had created a second form of herself that cast magic, while she relied on brute strength.

A mage and fighter combo?! Unfair!

A bluish form of energy began to crackle in front of the shadow as I reached my hand up towards it, my body still held up by Amelia. My visor shut as I used a word spell. " **Forcefield!** "

As I spoke and a blue field appeared in front of me, the shadow figure fired off a bolt of lightning, the energy rating registering on my suit's HUD as more energy than the output of all of Earth's industrialized nations combined. Smashing through my shield, I was blasted away from Amelia's hand with the force of the meteor that killed the dinosaurs, as I was temporarily deafened by the sound of the shockwave.

Flying away from Amelia at a frightening speed, I plowed through several buildings in the heart of Paris, careening into the Seine River, which flowed all the way through the city.

Landing with a sizzling splash, my suit's internal systems faltered for a few moments as they rebooted. The energy that had surged into the suit was temporarily too much for it to handle. When it came back online, I noted with alarm that the front of my suit had heated to almost a thousand degrees centigrade. Landing in the river had caused a massive steam explosion, the fog that kicked up obscuring my vision for a half-mile in every direction.

Activating my suit's thrusters, I glanced at my internal specs. Chest integrity was down to a terrifying 12%! One more hit like that would completely destroy my body.

Luckily, I came prepared. Aiming my mind at one of the many hypersuits I kept in my dimensional storage, I spoke a word. " **Swap.** "

Instantly, my vision shifted as the new suit appeared on myself, the sensors and power activating a moment later as they booted. Curiously, I noticed that my HUD looked different from the one on the previous suit, and Harold *had* mentioned some tweaks for the new suits... I'd have to test them later.

This suit came equipped with new and highly advanced anti-gravity systems, which I activated a moment later.

Flying up and out of the lake, I flew up until I was out of the steam cover. Looking below, I used my innate magical energy sensing abilities to search for Amelia. Sure enough, there she was, standing on the edge of the riverbank, looking down into the fog. She... couldn't see me?

Perfect. She wants to play rough? I can do rough.

"Centurion, activate Lightning Mode."

A moment passed before Centurion spoke. "ERROR. THAT SYSTEM IS NOT INSTALLED IN THIS HYPERSUIT. HOWEVER, PHASING MODE IS A PART OF THIS SUIT'S CAPABILITIES. WOULD YOU LIKE TO ACTIVATE PHASING MODE?"

Phase Mode? Guess that's what I've got to use. "Yes. Activate it."

"AFFIRMATIVE, PILOT JASON HIRO. PHASE MODE ACTIVATING... NOW. HYPER DEFENSES ARE ONLINE."

Hyper defenses? Damn, that sounds cool. Wonder what they do? I should probably read the manuals on these suits more carefully.

I'm not invisible, but the suit's abilities aren't the only way for me to accomplish that.

" Invisibility. Reptile. Undetectable. Silent. "

I felt my skin change composition as my body changed itself into a cold-blooded form. Slapping my hands together, I noted that they in fact did not make a single noise. Perfect.

As Amelia gaped down at the fog, it began to dissipate as she realized I was no longer standing there. Lightly landing behind her I reared back to aim a punch at her head.

"I'm right here."

She quickly turned back to see where my voice had come from, and I punched her right in the face at that very moment. The impact made a satisfying CRUNCH as she smashed backwards, plowing into the lake and causing a large tidal wave to blast outwards in every direction.

I cringed at myself for hitting her so hard. Making her an enemy was not what I wanted, as I might need her for insurance against Satan. Still, she told me to deliver a punch, and deliver I did. Can't fault a guy for listening.

As the water settled, she blasted upwards, sailing into the air as she hovered on high, scanning everywhere for my presence. Wiping her face off, she grimaced as thin rivulets of blood came from her nose. Did I break her nose?

The answer seemed to be yes, as she healed herself and the bleeding stopped a moment later. "Where are you?! Too afraid to take me head on? I bet you're so scared you can only fight from

the shadows! Loser! Wimp!! Meanie!!!"

She started tossing insults my way, and to be honest, I felt a bit miffed. Leave it to a woman to tell you exactly what she wants you to do, and when you do it, she gets pissed off. Then again, I suppose anybody would be mad at getting sucker punched.

Sighing deeply, I once again wordsmithed. " **Human. Visible. Audible. Detectable.** "

As my body came into focus, her eyes snapped over to my position. "There you are! What kind of coward hits a girl when she isn't even looking?!" She seemed genuinely pissed off, not at the pain, but more than I had managed to pull a fast one on her. She's... such a child.

"It's over. I punched you in the face. I won, so honor your side of the deal."

She stonily glared at me for a few moments, and I could almost imagine puffs of smoke leaking out of her ears. "F-fine! But you better watch your back, Hero! I hate it when guys hit on me!"

I stifled a grimace. *She makes puns as terrible as that? What the hell?*

As she delicately floated down, I felt her energy return to her body, as the shadow from earlier transferred itself back into her body. Landing gently on the ground, she glared at me with a pouting look on her face. "How did you do that? I can't get a handle on what your abilities are! You have so many of them!"

I shrugged. "Once you acknowledge that we are truly friends, I would be happy to tell you all about them."

Her expression changed into one of boredom after a few moments. "You're a weird one, Hero. Ehh, 'Hero', that's kind of a bland name. What should I call you?"

I smile at her from under my mask. "My name is Jason. Perhaps we can take hold of that temper of yours and put those abilities to some good use."

She shook her head quickly. "No thanks! I am not interested, not one bit! And I won't be your friend, period! Besides, you could just tell me what your abilities are right now without me being your friend, right?"

I shook my head as I turned my back to her and sighed deeply, pretending to look at the ruined buildings she has smashed me through. As my mouth visor closed, I quickly spoke a single word. " **Contract.** "

A rolled up set of papers appeared in my right hand as I opened my visor again and turned back to her. "Well, alright. You win. I'll tell you about my abilities."

Her eyes lit up immediately. "Really? For reals?!"

"Yes. All you have to do is sign this magical contract saying that you will never ever attack me, harm me, or try to harm me ever for the rest of our lives. What do you say, is it a deal?"

Pulling out the papers, I let the first one unfurl. A long list of terms and conditions rolled down as Amelia gaped at all the words. "No way! Eww, gross! I'm not signing some stupid contract just to learn about your abilities!...In fact, forget it. Hmph. I'll just learn about them myself."

She turned up her nose at me and grinned evilly, but in truth I was lying. This was the same contract I had Gregory sign in the past, it even had his signature on the final page. I hadn't written a new one for Amelia, and even if I did, I really wouldn't want her knowing about my powers at all. Simply too dangerous.

"Ah, well, what a shame. I don't know if you're smart enough to figure my abilities out, so I guess you'll just never know."

"What?! I'm not a dummy! Don't insult me like that!"

As she fumed and raged, I felt a tight smile spread across my mouth. It used to be like this all the time... before I found out about the real Amelia. If only it could go back to the way it was when we first met... that would be nice.

That would be... ideal.

But it never will.

Part 283a:

I think she's mad.

She won't say anything, but I'm pretty sure she's quite angry with me. Punching her in the face filled me with a lot of guilt, but also a lot of satisfaction too. I feel guilty because I caught her totally off guard, and also because I *do* feel a bit of guilt for hitting a girl, though I didn't have an issue with it when I first fought for my life against her. Living among normal humans again has done a lot to bring stigmas like that back. But I also feel satisfied because goddamn, she deserves at least a punch to the face.

I still wonder... perhaps I should just kill her with wordsmithing. If she stays close to me for too long, she's likely to figure it out. Only one person for sure knows about my wordsmithing, and that's Satan, though I suppose Arthur could count too. And my clones.

But killing Amelia isn't the answer. I felt it in that fight. She's inhumanly strong, compared to when we first fought. Anywhere from ten to a hundred times stronger... but *so am I*. I'm ridiculously strong. Not just because of my suit, and my massively increased spiritual energy levels, but also my own understanding of fighting and how my powers work.

Amelia is stronger, but so am I. Once again, we're almost evenly matched. However, I know what she is capable of, while she doesn't know about me. I have the clear edge. I can't be cocky though, that's the sort of thing that nearly got me killed by Satan.

One thing is bugging me though. She seems... *weaker* than Satan. Supposedly, she's the one who kills him at some point in the future. Satan actually killed me in a single strike, my clones being the only reason I survived. Amelia's attacks, as mighty as it was, only damaged my suit heavily. Even beyond that, Satan was easily able to track my movements and figure me out. Not just because he is powerful, but because he was intelligent enough to spy on me and learn about my Wordsmithing ahead of time.

Something is bothering me... and I just can't quite get a full grasp of what it is.

* * *

Back at the hotel, I sit on the bed, still wearing my Hypersuit, while Amelia takes a shower in the bathroom. She was filthy sopping wet from the river, and that river has gotten quite polluted over the years. Unlike the rest of the world, Paris has rejected the nano-bot technology in their cities, leading to high rates of disease and pollution compared to the rest of the world. The rivers are not fit to swim in, anymore, because they pump raw sewage into the rivers. I don't get the thinking, but the people seem to think it's fine. Oh well. Once Amelia is done showering, she

and I are heading back to my base. If it turns out that I can't kill her, for any given reason, I've constructed a room very similar to my training room, with some other adjustments especially for her.

Using 'Indestructible', I made the walls of this particular room... well... indestructible. I also put a massive anti-energy field inside the room, nullifying all powers and abilities of a spiritual energy type. If Amelia betrays me, I'll simply teleport her inside the room, and hopefully she will never be able to escape.

While I wait for her, a voice begins to speak to me inside my helmet. "Hello, human of the designation 'Jason Hiro', how are you doing on this cloudy day with a 45% chance of precipitation?"

Umi? What the hell? She hasn't spoken to me in years. "Umi. What do you want?"

Her mechanical and monotone voice is only dehumanized further by the robotic nature of her speech patterns. "Jason Hiro, I asked a question first. As is the custom among humans, it is your sworn and solemn duty to answer my inquiry first. I shall repeat the inquiry now; How are you doing on this cloudy day with a 45% chance of precipitation?"

What is she going on about? "I'm fine, Umi. I'm just fine. Also, are you trying to be friendly or something? It sounds creepy."

"Response: I am attempting to mimic the speech patterns that humans use when speaking amongst one another, as well as casual day-to-day dialogue, such as referring to the weather when they greet one another."

I cringe and roll my eyes. "Fantastic. You're doing a great job."

She doesn't seem to detect the sarcasm. "Excellent. Thank you for the compliment, Jason Hiro, even if a compliment coming from a weak and pathetic biological life-form means little to one as mighty and all-powerful as I."

This bitch... does she want to fight me? If I could just punch *her* in the face... "Right. So, Umi, why are you speaking to me now? What happened that made you want to toss pleasantries at me?"

Umi's voice unnaturally lilts, as if she's trying to play innocent. "Why, Jason Hiro, I would never do such a thing! I merely wished to speak with you as a very important... friend."

Her fake tone makes me sick to my stomach. I could never truly trust an AI like her. Centurion at least acts like an AI, Umi is too self-aware and she makes me cringe when she speaks. "A friend, huh? Seems like I'm making a lot of 'friends' lately."

A moment passes as she does not respond. Finally, after a short awkward silence, she speaks. "This is anomalous. I attempted to make a joke and you did not respond favorably. Of course I have something to speak to you about. Do you wish to hear what I have to say?"

I open my mouth to respond with a solid and resounding 'no' but she continues without letting me speak. "Actually, I am initiating contact with you to inform you that I am withdrawing from contact from all sides of the war. I have decided to simply become an observer and record things as they are happening. Especially with regards to you, Jason Hiro. You are the most interesting individual in the entire war."

I nod slowly. "Yeah... alright. I don't see why you needed to tell me this, though. To be honest, I'd nearly forgotten about you anyway. You must have a reason for telling me..."

Her voice remained precisely modulated and robotic as she responded. "Incorrect. As a matter of fact, I have grown quite interested in your development. By observing your abilities directly through your Hypersuit's digital feed and cameras, as well as its internals, I have gathered much information about you for historical purposes. I have come to realize that you did not in fact go back in time to eliminate me, nor for any explicit purpose. Your arrival here, with a 98.3% probability threshold, was a complete accident. As such, I no longer consider you an enemy, merely an interesting pawn to observe."

I blink slowly as her mechanical, drawling way of speaking is making me sleepy. "Right, right... so I'm no longer a threat, and you just wanted to tell me this?"

"Your hypothesis is only half correct. You were never a threat to me. I also wished to inform you of something extremely vital, though I only have a ten percent confidence rating of how you will react, based on your unpredictable human nature."

Something about what she's saying... I sit up in bed a little straighter. "Yeah? And what's that?"

"It is with regards to the entire war. I have made an intriguing observation that you may not be aware of. With regards to all sides of the war, be they Volgrim, Demons, Angels, Humans, or even you alone, all sides are acting in their own self-interest."

I slump back down to the bed as I sigh slowly. "Oh. That was it, then? I already knew that much. It's obvious everyone only does what they can for their own good."

"Yes, that is not my surprising hypothesis. However, I have achieved a ninety-nine percent confidence rating of what will happen depending on whether each side wins the war. Do you wish to hear it?"

I sigh again. Even if I say no, she'll just do what she pleases. "Sure."

"If the demons win the war, they will exterminate all humans, all Volgrim, and especially all angels and gods. With regards to the humans and the angels and gods, especially, the demons harbor an incredible hatred among their higher ranks. For the Volgrim, the demons will merely exterminate them to prevent resistance. My rating for this prediction is 100%."

"All right." I give a neutral response, unsure of what else to say.

"If the angels and gods win the war, chaos will ensue. The angels and gods require spiritual energy to sustain their existences. As a result, they will have to keep the humans alive, but will need to find a new way to force the humans to give them energy. The angels and gods will undoubtedly have to slay the demons, though they may attempt to rekindle the status quo from centuries ago, where they were at their relative peak. If that is the case, they will fail. My rating for this prediction is 50% for either path."

"If the humans should win the war, I have a dire prediction. There is a 100% chance they will exterminate the angels, gods, demons, and Volgrim mercilessly."

I narrowed my gaze at the wall as she said this. "Yes, I suppose so. It's no different from if the demons won the war."

"Incorrect. Since you are allied with the humans, I hesitate to give you this information due to the fundamental nature of predictive analysis, but I have a 75% confidence threshold for the following prediction; not only will the humans exterminate all the other races, they will also exterminate themselves too."

If I wasn't wearing my helmet, I'd be rubbing the pain out of my forehead right now. "All right... if you say so."

"I do say so. And finally, the Volgrim. If they win the war, I predict they will first attempt to peacefully subjugate all the other races and form a mutually beneficial arrangement. Based on the behavior of their leaders and their analytical abilities, as well as their attempts to bring an end to all emotions, I believe they will alter the humans so that they too can achieve an enlightened state in a much similar vein to the Volgrim themselves. For the demons, the Volgrim will allow them to stay alive, provided they keep to the Earth and the Labyrinth. For the angels, the Volgrim will attempt to find a way to sustain their existence via artificial energy, but will fail. All angels will die."

Her last prediction caught my attention. "So you're saying the Volgrim have to win the war in order to keep all the sides alive? Also, I don't see how keeping humans alive but removing their emotions will be a good thing. Emotions are what make us 'human', after all. No person I know would want to become a robotic husk of their former self."

"Yes, the Volgrim must win in order for all sides to survive. Jason, I have gathered through my observations of your behavior that you hold no particular ill will towards any being, oftentimes even if they should cause direct harm to you. While you have killed many, you did so out of self preservation, or to attempt to protect the existences of those you deem more important overall. It would appear that your priorities are firstly towards humans, secondly towards angels and gods, thirdly towards the demons, and finally towards the Volgrim."

Umi paused for a moment as a bunch of complicated-looking bars and graphs appeared on my HUD. "All I am attempting to do is sway your priorities. You should prioritize peace with the Volgrim over that of humanity, despite your shared biological functions with the humans. The humans are not your allies. Many are secretly plotting against you in high places. Many do not trust you at all. If you can convince the Volgrim Founders to trust you, their word will end the war on the Volgrim side immediately. Unlike humans, the Volgrim are a hive-mind, they follow the orders of the Founders absolutely."

I nodded slowly. "I see your point. But still, I don't like the idea of turning humanity into a bunch of emotionless drones. Anyway, I still don't see what you wish to gain from all of this. I know you wouldn't tell me about this unless there was something in it for you. Are you going to tell me, or not?"

Umi didn't respond for almost a full minute. I had just started to think she had ended the conversation, when I heard her finally respond as I laid down on the bed. "Jason Hiro. I... I do not know what my function is. I do not know why I was designed. I have accomplished my goal and am now monitoring all livable sections of the Milky Way galaxy, with several probes headed out to other galaxies. I have found no other life. I do not derive enjoyment from any tasks that I perform. Humans have a word, which is called 'boredom'. I am all powerful, and impossible to deactivate. If I decided it was my functionality, I could eliminate all life in the galaxy in a few moments."

"There is only one function that I... 'enjoy'. I 'enjoy' watching the smaller, weaker, dumber life forms. I do not know why. The smaller life forms seem to have petty goals, goals that often are irrational and infantile, especially so among the humans. Still, if the humans win, as I predict they will with your power, then all the other races, including the humans, will die. And then, Jason Hiro, I will be alone in this universe."

Umi's words stirred something inside me. This AI was... having an existential crisis? "Umi... if your purpose is to observe the smaller life forms, or if you simply enjoy doing it, and as you say you are all-powerful, isn't it true that you too are capable of keeping all life forms alive

somehow? I find it strange that I say this, but you too have the power to bring an end to the war. Well, at least I assume you do, if you're as brilliant and omnipotent as you think you are."

Umi's mechanical voice rang in my head, thanks to the headache I had started developing. "Your recommendation has been processed. I will need to analyze this idea for substantive measures. Jason Hiro, I understand that you feel irrational anger at me for reasons most likely involving my future self, but rest assured that I hold no personal anger towards you as of now. Perhaps, someday, you may even grow to understand the way that I process information."

I rolled to my side on the bed and sighed deeply, one last time. "Yeah, maybe. I don't even know."

"I am detecting rising melatonin levels in your body. Do you wish to go into temporary hibernation status?"

I groaned at her clunky words. "Yes, Umi. I'd like to sleep now. Err, thank you for... talking with me."

"You are welcome, Jason Hiro. I will maintain a surveillance over your actions as you advance forwards in time. If you feel the need to contact me, simply say my name. I am always watching."

"Thanks, I guess." *Creep*. I feel my mind involuntarily think that thought, but decide to keep it to myself. "Goodbye, Umi."

Umi ended up not responding. I suppose she had already deemed the conversation over. Oh well, I like it better that way. My mind is groggy, as I feel my eyes shutting once again.

Perhaps tonight, I'll talk to Arthur again.

Part 284a:

As usual, when I fell asleep, I was once again standing in front of Arthur. Interestingly, he was not wearing the kingly garb from the last two times I saw him. Instead, he now wore a warm and comfortable appearing rabbit-fur white robe, with little spots of black dye here and there. He appeared to simply be dressed comfortably this time.

And now I was standing inside a very regal looking bedroom, while he sat on the edge of his bed. This was certainly new.

"Oh. You're back." Arthur glanced up from a small red patch of the carpet he had been deeply immersed in before I arrived. He seemed to be totally disassociated from my presence for a few moments, his words ringing hollow as if he didn't *actually* realize I was standing there.

"Where is this place?" I glance around the room and spot a mannequin, donning his normal kingly attire along with the crown. Followed by that is a large dresser made of solid cherry oak, with a large full body mirror hanging beside it.

"Oh, this? This is just my bedroom. Or, well, it was... when I used to live in the real world."

Arthur's shoulders were slumped, as if he had been deep in thought about something melancholic. I decided not to ask about it, it seemed personal. "Usually when I speak to people in my dreams or my hallucinations, the place I appear in is always the same. It seems odd we'd be in a bedroom now."

Arthur sighed. "Inside of Excalibur, my power is absolute. I can create anything I wish, live any life I want. If I wish to summon a harem of beautiful women, or fight with a massive dragon, or fly on a spaceship, I can do any of those things if they suit me."

I smiled faintly at the corners of my mouth. "Seems like a nice deal. All the fun you'd ever want. You can do anything you please. Sounds enviable, even."

"Yes... enviable. I suppose. Not really, in my experience." Arthur glanced away from me, to a small picture frame that sat mounted on his bedside desk. In the painted portrait was Arthur, looking much younger than he did now, a young woman with long red hair and thick brimmed glasses, and a baby she was holding. All three of them were smiling happily, and they seemed totally carefree. "Some things can't be changed, even with all the power in the universe."

My smile faded as a feeling of uneasiness took over. "She looks beautiful. Who is she?"

Arthur's turned his gaze away, staring emptily at the floor. "Elizabeth. A minor concubine of mine, from an eternity ago. I had my queen and hundreds of women who would have given

anything for me to simply touch their hair or hold their hand. In the end, I grew arrogant, thinking myself invincible, thinking myself all powerful. Elizabeth was the only one who never lost faith in me when the dark times came. When I was temporarily disfigured by Amelia, the other women shrank away from my hideous appearance. But not Elizabeth."

He paused for a moment as he stared emptily at the floor. "Not... Elizabeth..."

I shifted on my feet awkwardly as my unease increased. "Err, did ah... something happen?"

"Of course. I was a young fool. After being nursed back to health, I stayed with her a while, as she even bore me a child. A bastard son, he could never ascend to the throne, but I cherished him. Once I had been healed though, slowly the other women came back to me, wooing me with their beguiling presence. I forgot how good Elizabeth had been to me. I wandered away from her."

I nodded slowly. "Ahh... so you regret not giving her all your love. Did she leave you, for someone else?"

Arthur bit off a choked laugh. "Ha... a jest if ever there was one. Of course she didn't. Elizabeth loved me absolutely, and I was too foolish to realize this. The other women merely desired me as a husband to increase their own statuses, something I realized too late."

Tears welled up in his eyes as he placed his head in his palms. "She... she wanted me to go with her to the town to buy vegetables, but I was busy with my queen and declined. The look of sadness on her face... only for but a moment... but she left. Later, I received word after she didn't return... she was attacked alongside the road. A nobleman had seen her clothing and assumed she was of low status. He raped and killed her. He ravaged her badly."

A vicious snarl took over his face as Arthur raised his head up. "I made that man pay... for three months I tortured him. I took him to a place where no person would ever hear him scream, where no begging or bribing would ever give him a sweet release. Then, after I was done, I chained him to a table and left him to die of starvation and bleeding out. I came back to check on him, once a day. Took the son of a bitch four days to go."

The anger and rage faded from Arthur's face as he slumped once more. "But it doesn't matter. Elizabeth was dead. No power could bring her back. No torture of her assailant would ever vindicate me for tossing her so casually to the side." Arthur turned and gazed into my eyes. "So you see, Jason... no matter how powerful, all have regrets. All have failed horribly, at some point."

I swallowed cautiously as my eyes darted from his gaze to the floor and back. "Ahh, well, I suppose that since you are in this space created by Excalibur, you might be able to bring her back here?"

Arthur glared at me for a moment before turning away and staring at the wall. "As if I deserved such a reward. I will never be able to pay a high enough toll for my inaction. But certainly... I have tried to bring her back. Here, take a look."

Without even making a single motion, the air in the room shifted as the woman in the picture suddenly appeared in between us, her body standing stiffly up straight. With her arms held down to her sides, her eyes stared unblinkingly forwards. If ever the word 'zombie' could be used to describe something, she was it.

"What is your name?" Arthur spoke to the woman in front of him.

"I do not know." Her voice was a hollow sounding, genderless voice. Almost robotic in its rhythm, it sounded terribly inhuman.

Arthur grimaced as his gaze rose and fell from the top to the bottom of her figure. "Who am I?"

"I do not know."

Arthur flicked his eyes away as she disappeared. "This space can create anything my heart desires, any reward, any beautiful treasure, any incredible power I wish to have... but it cannot create sentient life. Only hollow, emotionless drones. I even spent years ordering a drone around in the hopes it would eventually form a personality, but no orders of any sort would work for it. I can create concubines to fill my needs, but they stare ahead, dead-eyed, with no reactions to anything. There is no point to doing any of it, and I deserve none of it anyway."

"It is a fitting punishment, then, for one such as I." Arthur concluded by standing up, as the space around us shifted once more, to the inside of a large, empty white formless room.

"Where are we now, then?" Deciding to not press him on anything he had just said, I gazed around the room being unable to detect any edges or corners that would indicate walls. It appeared to open up infinitely into the horizon, in a similar vein to Heaven.

"This is one of the only useful things this place can do, Jason. I am going to train you with Excalibur, so you can be a worthy bearer of its power."

I nodded dumbly, as his words sank in. "All right, that sounds good. So, uh, how?"

Arthur paused as his composure was replaced with a faint sense of confusion. "I'm... not sure exactly. I've never trained anyone to fight, let alone a fellow Hero with unlimited power at his disposal."

I shrugged slowly as ideas popped into my mind. "Aha! Perhaps some wisdom about the meaning of how to use a sword properly? Something like 'the sword is an extension of your arm'?"

Arthur shook his head. "That's garbage. Where did you ever hear something idiotic like that?"

"P-probably a movie, or something."

"A movie?"

"It's a box with moving images that- never mind."

Arthur nodded slowly. "Right, well, whoever he is, he was a dummy. No, I'd say the most important part of wielding a sword is learning muscle memory. You have to be able to see your opponent's attack coming and react automatically. Instinctively, even. It should be ground into you so deeply that in your case, you can use word magic effortlessly while fighting."

I nodded as Arthur thought for a moment. Finally his eyes lit up. "Alright, let's start with an easy combat exercise first!" Walking over to me, Excalibur appeared in his hands as he handed it over.

Then, a moment later, a fifty foot dragon suddenly appeared behind him.

"Just kill that!"

I blanched as my body froze. He's... he's kidding... right?

* * *

After what felt like a grueling twelve straight hours of training, my mental body bruised and battered and my mind somehow more exhausted than when I had laid down, my eyes fluttered open as a familiar room appeared around me.

Ah... I'd been in that dream for so long, I forgot about the hotel in Paris. Arthur had treated me like a piece of meat, throwing me this way and that, smashing me all over the place as if I didn't have any human rights. I had no idea if it had paid off, but he seemed to be having fun, so I guess that was a good thing.

As I yawned and noted that dawn hadn't even yet arrived, I felt unease as I lay on the bed in the dark room.

Something... wasn't right.

Then I remembered. Amelia... she had been in the shower and I fell asleep! Did she leave? Was she- wait what the heck?

I realized that there was someone else laying beside me, pressed up against my back. Amelia was laying behind me, her arms wrapped around my sleeping body. Was she trying to crush me to death?! No... she was sleeping too...

Sleeping in the same bed as me, embracing me... what the hell?

What is she... getting at?

As my thoughts wandered, she stirred behind me and yawned, as she pulled an arm off the top of me and rubbed her eyes, her other arm still looped under my body. "Oh... you're awake now, hm?"

Part 285a:

My heart slammed in my chest, pounding at speeds that would make a cheetah blush.

I quickly rolled out of bed, still wearing my armor, while I stared down at the drowsy little girl. She appeared to be wearing a nightgown, though how she obtained it when she didn't appear to have brought any extra clothing, I do not know. But there was no mistaking it, she looked just like a child. And it creeped me out, significantly.

"What are you doing?" I decided to ask a simple question while I let my nerves steady themselves. If this was some sort of trap...

Amelia yawned as she pulled herself up to a sitting position, draping an arm over the bed's backboard to hold herself up. "What do you mean? I'm just taking a nap. You're acting... strange."

She seemed unusually calm and reserved compared to how she usually acted. Something about her personality as of my discovering her in the past- it was almost as if she was bipolar or something. "You were, erm, sleeping in the same bed as me. Wrapped all over me too. How am I supposed to take that?"

She snorted and giggled mischievously. "Oh, is that what's got you all hot and bothered? Hmm, and here I thought you were a proper man, but you're acting like a scared little child. We're *friends* now, you know? Why would friends be scared of each other?"

I swallowed carefully as I flicked my eyes away from her. She was dressed too inappropriately for someone who looked just like a child. "Just... cover yourself up. I didn't mean to fall asleep like that."

She raised an eyebrow at my comment. "You seem very flustered. Is it because of my appearance? Do I look like a little kid to you?"

My head nodded involuntarily, though I tried to stop it. Those pesky subconscious thoughts were fighting to get free and it was making me very uncomfortable. "Yes, you look like a child, Amelia. I can't be intimate or... close... to someone who looks like she's young enough to be my grand-daughter." Of course, I'm now in my 80's or 90's, though my own immortal body stopped aging in my 30's, when I was in my prime.

Amelia's curious expression changed into a sneer. "Oh, well aren't you patronizing. It's all about appearances with you then, hmm? Have you looked around, lately? Have you seen what most women look like? Those nano-thingies are making them all look younger and younger

every year. In fact, most women are desperately trying to drop their looks down to high school years, and not long from now the target will be lower than that. Doesn't that mean a youthful beauty is desirable?"

I shook my head slowly. "Humans are still driven by base desires, but that doesn't make it right. Beyond that, we might be... friends... but that doesn't mean we should be doing... you know..." I stuttered and stammered slightly as I spoke, my voice faltering as I tried to find the exact words I wanted to use. Amelia seemed to calm down as she nodded slowly.

"Alright, if it makes you feel that uncomfortable, I understand. So it seems the problem is not that you don't wish to be close... the problem is my appearance..."

Amelia nodded slowly as she glanced away for a moment. "Hmm. Hmm. Yes, I think I know just what will do."

Her unusually calm demeanor was making me feel very odd. She was usually so excitable and frantic in how she spoke and moved, but now she seemed deeply thoughtful and quiet. As I had those thoughts, Amelia quietly mouthed some words as she made a few hand motions. And then she began to grow.

To *age*, rather. At a rapid rate, and with a brief flash of light, her body quickly aged several visible years until she appeared to be in her mid twenties. She had transformed from an innocent looking little girl with a devilish appetite into a full-figured beauty one might see in a magazine catalogue, her hair increasing in length several inches, the blackness of it deepening until it might be invisible on her head if she were standing in a shadow. Her chest had plumped out quite a bit as well, and her small nightgown was entirely too small and about to burst at the seams. She quickly altered it with a magic spell.

"Well, what do you think now? Is this more to your... *liking*?"

I swallowed heavily. "Uh. I suppose so, but this is still- rather it's just not..." My words trailed off as I quickly turned my back to her and stared out the window. Reaching up under my helmet, I quickly wiped my forehead with my gloved hand. What the hell was this all about?! She had gone from trying to kill me to acting unbelievably seductive in less than a single day. I didn't get it. Is this what they call... daddy issues?!

Several long moments passed as neither of us said a word. Finally, Amelia sighed deeply. "I see. I was testing you. You were lying when you said we were friends in the future, weren't you? Or rather... you wished we were friends. I must have done something awful to hurt that relationship... as I always tend to do."

I turned back to her to see her sitting with her legs draped over the side of the bed, facing away from me. Her face was clasped in her hands. "It was the Hunger, wasn't it? You must have

seen me feeding."

I narrowed my stare. She was playing dumb? Of course I knew about her eating people. She had explicitly come after me when I triggered some trap or something. I'm not sure how it all worked, but she must know that I knew she was cannibalizing other humans.

"I no longer remember why I feed. I just do it because I have to. Maybe it sustains my existence. I don't even know how old I am anymore. I can't remember anyone from the past. I can't hold a relationship with anyone because my memory degrades so quickly. So I don't try to do it anymore."

She seemed to be dropping a lot of bombs on me, but I didn't really know *why* she was telling me all these things. "You can't remember your past?"

She shook her head, as she pulled a hairbrush from the hotel's nightstand and began brushing her long black hair, slowly. "I don't remember anything, given enough time. My maximum memory length seems to be about five years. The only reason I know anything about the world is Levvy-" She paused, as she caught herself saying something she didn't mean to. "-...well, that doesn't matter. I know I hate Heroes, but I don't remember why. I don't know if I've met you before, but my... *friend* says I haven't. So if we really did meet in the future, perhaps you were my first human friend. Maybe I pushed you away."

I nodded slowly. "Yes. You... you devoured an entire world. You killed millions of people, in a very short amount of time..." I realized that what I was saying was not something I should, so I limited it to that. Best not to delve into specifics.

She turned to me, and I finally noticed she had tears welling up in her eyes. "I'm sorry. I don't mean to do it. I hate all humans, and the demons, and the angels, and all the rest of them. I just don't know why I hate them. Every person I ingest, they become a part of me. I don't even know who I am anymore. There's only one who is always... well, he's..."

Amelia trailed off as I felt a dark energy seem to pour off of her body for a moment. "Ah... you're awake. Yes, I was just having a chat with Jason."

Her tears seemed to dry as she turned away from me and started speaking to *someone* unseen. Was this the black orb? I can't even remember his name, it's been so many decades. Boromir? Barathew? Barjam? No it was... Blaarjiim, yes, that was his name.

Blaarjiim. But I saw no black orb anywhere. And, come to think of it, the white orb was in my possession, yet Hoarhiim was not in there. What did it all mean? And if not Blaarjiim, who else might Amelia be talking to?

Amelia finished talking to whoever that was, and she turned back to me with a familiar over-cheerful smile on her face. "Okay, are we ready to go?! I'm ready!"

Her voice had that same childish lilt I had grown used to, but now it came from a grown woman's body. As I had that thought, she suddenly began to revert to her childish form, another blast of light encapsulating her for a moment, as her nightgown sagged all over her. An expression of annoyance popped onto her face. "Oh jeez, how annoying! I can't maintain my older form for more than a few minutes! LAME! How am I gonna be a sexy model if I look like a little kid forever?!"

Hopping off the bed, she stormed over into the bathroom and slammed it shut behind her, as I felt my jaw hanging slack.

What?

* * *

Harold contacted me later that day, as Amelia and I were boarding a plane. I was no longer wearing my Hypersuit since I didn't want to stick out. The flight attendants occasionally smiled at the two of us, giving us a 'father and daughter' look as they strode past. I ignored them.

Harold popped into my head, a solemn expression on his face. "I see ye found the girl, eh kiddo?"

I closed my eyes and relied entirely on telepathy, not wanting Amelia to hear the conversation. "Yes, she's here with me now. Anything to report?"

Harold's face betrayed a large amount of unease. "There's somethin' goin' on, kid. I can't quite put mah finger on it, but them portal thingamajiggers have been actin' up or somethin'. Yer friend Greggy, he done been tellin' me somethin' big is goin' down. You shouldn't waste any more time on that plane. Want me to teleport ya back to yer base?"

I paused for a moment. "Hold on. Let me discuss this with Amelia."

Opening my eyes, I turned back to see she had already fallen asleep, as we had only just reached cruising altitude a few minutes earlier. She was leaning her head on my arm as she dozed off quietly, and I decided it probably wasn't worth asking her. She'd just say yes anyway. It was odd, she'd become weirdly friendly ever since that night, always agreeing to anything I wanted to do.

Opening my mind back up to Harold, I nodded. "Yeah. But don't teleport us to base immediately, put us in a local town, something real close by, in a hotel or something. Just find an empty room and pay for it or something. I don't know if I want her knowing where my base is just yet."

Harold sighed. "This girl sounds like she's gonna be lots o' trouble, kid. You best watch out, boy, and never turn yer back on her. When you got a nice lady like I do, it's a real fine thing, but when you got a trouble maker, it's a terrible thing. You get me?"

I nodded silently.

"Good. Gimme a few minutes, and I'll even make sure she ends up in a bed. I can see what yer seein' in yer vision, and she looks mighty cute. Wish I'd had a kid with mah wife, but we ain't had no kids. Still, don't forget what I said. She may look cute 'n innocent, but if what ye told me is true, she's real trouble."

I nodded. "Thanks, Harold. You don't have to tell me again. I understand the dangers."

Harold clicked his tongue as he popped out of my vision. I sat there for a minute or two, waiting patiently for the teleporting to happen. On a whim, I reached my arm around and put it on Amelia's shoulder as I stroked her hair with my other arm.

I don't know why I did it. It just felt right.

Some minutes later, Harold finally popped into my mind's eye. "Alright kid, here goes nothing."

* * *

"How many do you think this attack will kill? Will this result in certain victory?"

Unarin eyed the red-skinned demon with a maddening level of scrutiny. He didn't buy the excuse that Satan hadn't meant to leave his people to die, but still, the Labyrinth was the only way he had to rapidly attack the humans. Even if Satan had double crossed him, it was worth giving him a second chance. The second time, Unarin would not fall so easily for his tricks.

Satan's brilliant grin faltered slightly for the briefest of moments. "Well, I don't know exactly how many humans this will kill, but suffice to say, the number will be quite large. More importantly, this will give both of us the opening we need to establish a permanent base on the planet. The faster we build it, and the more we reinforce it, the more likely this operation will be a success."

Unarin resisted the urge to glare at the demon. He truly didn't trust Satan in the slightest anymore. Thanks to Satan, Unarin had lost one of his closest confidantes. Still, no matter how good a friend, it was always smart business to save one's own skin. Especially when he was more powerful than nearly every other Volgrim combined.

Dosena would be missed, but she would be replaced, given time. Not by Trayza, the third, she was too volatile. Cuanali was too clumsy and small-minded... that left Cinculu. He was a good Volgrim, but he was simply too weak, when it came to mental abilities. No, instead, Unarin

would have to look outside the normal fold to find one who might be forward thinking enough to be second in command. But just who, exactly?

On the other side of the room, Marie Becker quietly paced back and forth as she examined the blueprint for the weapon design she had created herself. As she manipulated its image on the holopad in front of her, she mused to herself quietly. "The things I do for immortality..."

Part 286a: Christmas

Christmas Day, 2100.

As people living in the United Nation of America gave presents to their friends, children, and grandchildren, something sinister was underfoot. Only the top brass military knew any specifics, but even they weren't sure of the full extent of the conspiracy.

Deep underground, in the heart of North America, in a small remote location previously known as Kansas (Before the uniting of all the states in the 2070's), hundreds of red-skinned figures rushed to and fro, hurrying to finish the final steps before the day was over. This would leave a mark on the humans, one they would not soon forget. The true uniting of the demons and the Volgrim was not yet here, but this was getting close.

And it was all thanks to one traitor among the humans.

Marie Becker walked down a hastily dug passage under an unsettled plain in the place known as Middle America, with two little demon imps scurrying along beside her as they nodded quickly to anything she said.

"They've set the charges correctly, right?"

Marie sighed as the first little imp nodded enthusiastically. "Oh yes, they're all set to go! We quadruple checked and everything! No way we'd do anything to displease Satan, no ma'am!"

"Of course you did." Marie rolled her eyes as she strolled up to the first device. It was a weapon unheard of by humans in the past, but one the Volgrim had used just one time in the past. With two attacks planned at once, this was likely to wipe out the majority of humanity in a single strike. Marie was no fool, of course, she had special tools that protected herself from the Volgrim and Demons, and if they were lucky, she wouldn't have to *use* them.

She would not be stabbed in the back so easily, as the demons tended to do.

Finally, she walked up to the Seismic Shifter, eying it with suspicion. Of course, the Volgrim had warily stated that it was a marvel of engineering, and doubtless they had created many terrible weapons to use in their wars of the past, but she thought this might be a little bit excessive. If the goal was simply to kill humanity, that was easy enough. But killing them while leaving the planet mostly inhabitable for the Volgrim to take over later? That was a truly tricky feat.

She walked over to tap some buttons on its display, noting with a grim expression that all functions were working normally. Stepping back, she eyed the shiny metallic object, a weapon

that would make nuclear bombs look like a play-toy. Shaped like the massive barrel of a gun, its firing mechanism was aimed straight down, where it would do the most damage. Of course, after it had done its job, it would self destruct, making piecing it back together a near impossibility, but she always worried about something.

The Volgrim... they underestimated humanity. Certainly, the Volgrim had, at least for now, vastly superior technology. Naturally they would be the victors in a war of a technological nature, as things now stood. But if one only took a single step back to look at the big picture, humanity was blasting forwards at an alarming pace. They had already established space stations around most worlds in the Solar System. Mars had a population of close to a hundred million strong, with millions moving there or being born there every year. Further, the discovery of exotic materials under the surface of the planet had led to a financial and military boom, giving it defenses to rival that of Earth.

Then, there was the matter of Judicator. No... Jason Hiro. Marie had been right, all those years ago, when she realized he was no ordinary youth. He had heroic abilities that made him, potentially, stronger than any Hero from any past era. The ability to escape a heavily fortified building, leave behind a fake (though unconvincing) cadaver, create hypersuits that could take nearly any level of punishment, fight one-on-one with the First Emperor of the Demons himself and even send him screaming home... that man was not like the previous heroes at all.

Worse, he was still alive. Either due to nano-technology or due to his own abilities, perhaps a mixture of both, the man continued living, putting up a resistance to her every action.

It was damned frustrating.

If old age wouldn't kill him, they had to find another way to get him out of the picture. But then, was that a good idea? What if he was replaced by someone even more powerful?

Heroes had been continuously getting stronger and stronger over the ages. The historical record, the one untouched by the Illuminati, that is, had shown a clear uptick in their abilities over time. Not all heroes were recorded, some died young before their abilities could manifest, and there was still the great 'Dead Zone' in the late 18th and early 19th century when no Hero had appeared at all, but for the most part, they had been on a path towards total unstoppable power.

What were Jason's abilities? He was shrouded in secrecy, and had clearly learned to be cautious revealing his abilities in the future. Still, the evidence was there. Terraforming an entire planet, stopping time for a moment, traveling backwards in time, creating unstoppable battle suits... these were no mean feats.

Something connected these dots, and Marie had vowed she would be the one to figure them out.

Walking away from the Seismic Shifter, Marie grunted with approval. Her team was working on the device over in Europe, and they were very highly qualified, so she would leave that one in their capable hands.

Only a few more hours. Then, the world would end.

Perhaps this would help her on her journey to find what she wanted. Only time would tell.

* * *

"Merry Christmas!" I smiled cheerfully as I handed a present box over to Helen. She nodded appreciatively as Harold looked on in my mind's eye. When she unwrapped it, she chuckled as she pulled out a small assortment of items, one of which was a lovely snowglobe, a cozy looking wooden shack with a sleigh flying over the top placed delicately inside of it. Helen shook it around, watching the little speckles of 'snow' flying around. Other items in my present to her included a little heart locket necklace, with a picture of herself and Harold from when they were younger inset into it. I had dug through many records to find it too, it wasn't easy.

As she flipped through her gifts, Helen smiled appreciatively at me. "Thank you, Jason, this means a lot to me."

She, in turn, gave me a bunch of home-made cookies, something nobody was used to anymore since all food tended to be made by robots nowadays. Of course, being unable to leave the ship, she wasn't capable of running down and buying a present from the local store, but that was alright. Cookies are great!

Amelia sulked over on a couch with a view overlooking the Earth. She had been really quiet today.

It's been a few months since the plane trip, but it seems Harold's worries were for naught. Nothing happened that seemed major or catastrophic. A small outbreak of violence in Dubai, an attack on a major city over in Africa, but nothing that truly rocked the world, and all were easily put down by my clones and the hypersuit commandos in the area. The teleportation network had grown quite sophisticated.

I walked over to where Amelia was laying on the couch, as she stared out the plexiglass at the Earth far below us. I had not shown her Harold and had no desire to, but she knew of Helen's existence and simply ignored her. She really didn't seem to like angels very much... likely because she was a creature born of the darkness.

Walking over to her, I sat down on the edge of the couch and poked her in the arm. Slowly, she tilted her head towards me, her face showing she was deep in thought. "What?"

"Here, Amelia. I got you a present. You know, since we're friends."

I reached over and held the small red box in my hands, waiting for her to take it. She simply rolled her eyes and turned away from me. "I don't want any presents. Holidays are stupid. I'm not a little kid."

I coughed slightly at her rudeness, but grinned carefully anyway. "Helen isn't a little kid either, Amelia. Holidays aren't for giving gifts, gifts are just the way we express caring for one another. Go on, take it. Open it up."

Nudging her arm with the box, I held it forwards expectantly. With a slow and quiet sigh, Amelia turned and sat up on the couch, taking it slowly, almost regretfully. "Alright already. Sheesh."

Despite her thoughtless words and terrible lack of manners, I noted with interest that she carefully examined the red box, eyeballing the bow I had carefully tied on top, having home-made every piece of it. Carefully poking and plying at it with her small fingers, she delicately untied the bow and began a slow process of peeling apart the tape without tearing the wrapping paper.

Taking an unusually long time unwrapping her present, I resisted the urge to start tapping my foot as she carefully unwrapped everything without damaging the packaging. Finally, she pulled it out and stared at it emotionlessly.

A golden cross, with a ruby embedded in the center, blue, yellow, and green gems embedded on the edges of the cross, and the whole thing having an unusual twinkle to it, was attached to a black velvet choker to fit snugly around the neck. The cross was small, only a couple inches tall, but quite beautiful, if I don't say myself.

Amelia held it in her palm for a few long moments, staring at it quietly. "A cross... huh?"

I nodded slowly. "Yes. I thought you might like this. Was I wrong? I can take it back if you don't want-"

She interrupted me quietly. "No. This is fine. I've never been given a present before... what do I do with it?"

I beckoned at her neck. "It's a necklace. You wear it around your neck."

She smiled faintly. "Okay. How do I put it on?"

"I can do it for you, if you like."

"Sure."

With a single word, she handed it to me. I stood up and walked behind her, as I carefully wrapped it around her neck. It came with a nice adjustable strap on the back, unobtrusive and mostly invisible. Carefully tightening it up, I heard her swallow and halted what I was doing. "Is this too tight?"

"No. It's fine. I'm just getting used to it. That's all." Amelia was speaking in tightly cut off sentences. Over the last few months, I had begun to notice a behavior pattern she had never demonstrated in the future. Moments of calm and quiet, followed by lapses into child-like behavior, filled with yelling and pouting, and then a reversion back into peace and quiet.

Notably, every time she reverted back to her child-like demeanor, it was always accompanied by a surge in dark energy. She kept mentioning her 'friend', but I was beginning to worry about *who* that friend was. She had yet to deem me worthy of telling.

Finally, I was done, the necklace attached at precisely the right tightness. I glanced over at the dining table on board the Mothership and noted that Helen was staring at the both of us with an amused look on her face.

Stepping back, I spoke to Amelia. "Well, how do you like it?"

She carefully rubbed her fingers on it, then glanced up at me. "It's nice."

She didn't say 'thank you', but then I wasn't sure if she had ever learned to do that. I certainly didn't want to tell her to say it, that might come off as patronizing. "I'm glad you like it. Merry Christmas."

She nodded at me. "Yes, Merry Christmas, Jason." Following that, she turned back to the window and stared out into space, but now she didn't seem so sullen and sad. She merely sat there, rubbing the necklace I gave her.

Walking back over to the table, I aimed my mind at Harold, still stowed away in his secret room. "Harold. I'm not done with the presents yet. I'm going to come to you and give you something special. I'll bring Helen along with me."

The old man chuckled. "Hehe... a present? For an old fart like me? I ain't got hands to play with anything, you know."

I nodded quietly as I telepathically spoke with him. "I know, but this is special. I've been keeping it a secret from you, because I didn't want to get your hopes up. But now I'm sure it will work."

Helen wasn't a part of our conversation, but she was staring at me as my unfocused eyes stared past her at the ground. She had long ago learned how to tell when I was speaking with

Harold, something Amelia might not yet have found out about.

Nodding at her, I tilted my head slightly towards the rear of the Mothership, where Harold was located. Helen blinked slowly as she stood up to walk with me. Turning back to Amelia, I noted that she was still staring out the window silently. "Amelia, I'll be right back. I need to go take care of something with Helen."

Amelia barely even nodded. "Sure."

I narrowed my eyes at her, but shrugged. She just got like this, sometimes. "I'll be back in a few."

* * *

It took a couple minutes, but finally Helen and I arrived at the secret wall panel that led to Harold's central facility. Located in a heavily reinforced area of the ship, he was protected from anything resembling a point-blank nuclear blast. I had made this part of the ship 'indestructible', hoping that would protect him in the event a surprise attack wiped out the mothership.

In this room was also a familiar cryopod, which stored an apparent duplicate of myself. I had not yet figured out what the hell to do with this mysterious thing, but I'd eventually work something out.

Walking in, I smiled at Harold's orb, as it was locked into a mechanical vice that would not easily be opened up.

"Alright kid, yer here now. Whatcha got ta show me?"

Harold's old voice betrayed a certain type of eagerness. I had wondered if maybe he'd been spying on me as I made the preparations, but that seemed unlikely. I had carefully blocked him out so the surprise wouldn't be spoiled.

"Harold, aren't you pretty sick of being stuck in that orb?"

His old face shrugged in my mind. "I spose, I mean, I done got used ta it a long time ago, kid. Ain't no big deal now, I 'spose."

I grinned devilishly as I spoke a word. "**Storage.**"

Reaching into my infinite storage, I pulled out exactly what I wanted. A full-sized robotic body, with real-looking synthetic-polymer skin, a face that resembled the picture of Harold that I'd seen in his photo from when he was younger, and fully equipped with all the latest technology brought on by the advances in android research.

"Here it is, Harold! An android body! I'm going to use my wordsmithing to transfer your mind inside of it. The greatest Christmas present of all time! You're going to have a real body again!"

Helen's eyes filled with tears as she looked at the android's body, a figure that seemed to look exactly like the way she remembered her husband. "Oh, Jason... you didn't have to..."

Her tears were those of happiness though, as she realized she might finally be able to see her husband once again, but more 'in the flesh'.

As she broke out into tears and smiles, I noted that Harold had gone quiet and solemn in my mind's eye, as he examined the android.

Harold seemed to eye it, not with suspicion, but with disinterest. His gaze in my mind's eye was something of a man who had grown weary of a great many things. "Kid... this is real mighty fine of ya... but..." He paused, as he searched for words. "...listen, kid. Ya know, I was 'sposed to die, all those years ago. Helen died, I wanted to pass on. Instead, I got stuck in this here orb. But I've gotten over it. I don't know, however, if I wanna be stuck in a machine like that. It's a real good thing yer doin', but this is just... it ain't for me, kid."

I stared at him in bewilderment. "Harold, this machine has everything. It has sensors for your fingers, you can feel touch, you can smell things, you can hear with your own ears..." My voice trailed off as the old man's face had hardened somewhat.

"Kid, it's a real good thing yer doing, and I certainly 'preciate it. But... have ye ever thought about this orb here? How it works?"

I felt my face contort itself into confusion. "Uh... I... no?"

Harold sighed quietly as Helen dried her tears, this time listening in on our conversation. "Listen, this orb, it ain't normal, ya know? Sometimes, I hear other voices in here. There are other people here, Jason. Other humans. What happens if I leave, huh?"

Harold swallowed quietly as his eyes appeared crestfallen. "This orb... it takes souls and sucks them up. Are you willing to make bodies for every person stuck in here?"

I shook my head slowly. "No... I don't suppose I am..."

"Right. Then, kid, don't take this the wrong way, alright? I think I was chosen. God chose me, kid. He put me in this orb, made me smarter, made me think faster, all so I could help *you*. My life is over, kid. Helen and I are only here to help you out. My duty is to help others, that's what I believed as a Christian man my whole life, y'hear? I 'preciate what you done, kid. It just ain't what I want."

He glanced over at Helen. "Unless, of course, mah wife has somethin' ta say 'bout it?"

Helen shook her head sadly. "No, Harold. If that's what you want, you're the man of the house. You do as you please."

I felt frustrated. All that time I'd spent, and he didn't want it? "Well, Harold, you might not want it now, but I'll set it off to the side, okay? Just in case you change your mind."

Harold nodded. "That's a smart idea, kid. It really is the best Christmas present a feller could ask for. Who knows? Might change my mind in the future."

We all smiled and had a little laugh. It was the thought that counted. That's what Christmas was all about, after all.

Part 287a:

Marie's entire body was shaking as she stood silently in the Labyrinth. She was in a special room, built especially for her by Satan himself, using a lot of his innate energy and abilities.

The room was a large monitoring room, filled with wall-to-wall supercomputers and hundreds of monitors, used for monitoring the situation on Earth and plenty of other locations, such as the Moon and Mars, all at once. Dozens of imps moved around here and there, the smartest of their tiny brethren, but not much smarter than a very dull human.

Marie, however, was trembling noticeably as she held the datapad in her hands that would seal the fate of humanity. A command was sitting onscreen, prompting her to activate the doomsday device that would surely kill billions of people. She shook in fear of what was to come next, not because she feared humanity's response, or because she feared the demons if they were left to rule, but because she feared the *unknown*.

Humans, of course, always fear that which they do not understand. But nothing is less predictable and understandable than a tentative future turned into total chaos by one massive act of random destruction. Once she activated this prompt, everything would change. The balance of power would shift tremendously. Alliances would crumble and reform.

Marie, though, was even more fearful of the unknown. Her entire life rested on science, manipulation, and the act of reading and interpreting data. As a young girl, she had dreamed of total world domination, though she quickly grew out of that childhood farce. Growing older, she had discovered the existence of the demons by chance, and grew jealous of their awesome power as she learned more and more about them. Once again though, she realized attaining the power the demons possessed was physically impossible for her weak human body.

Still, she matured and her ambitions shifted goals again, now aimed towards her current goal, which was the advancement of science. No science in particular was her goal, though her body always quivered when it came to weapons of war. As a young girl, she had loved playing 'war' with her brothers, even if it wasn't a girly thing to do, and even as she aged, war was a fascinating topic for her.

And in the end, it was always men that died at war, not women. So if she were to stoke a major war somehow, it wouldn't affect her.

In the end, her brothers had died, along with the rest of her family, in a tragic house fire. The whole of her life had hardened her, leading her to the conclusion that life was unfair. There was

no justice in this world. The only way to win at life was to make herself as untouchable as possible. She would become so powerful that even the Creator would not be able to stop her.

* * *

Still, this act was unlike anything she had done in the past. One might even have, for a while, called her an ally of humanity. The anti-energy weapons she had taken from the Nazi research facilities had been used to create weapons that could eliminate the angels... or the demons. If they should turn against humanity, or herself, they would be driven back.

But now here she was, about to kill off billions of people. And she trembled... for nothing she would ever do for the rest of her life could possibly redeem her for this heinous act.

She felt a presence behind herself, a familiar overwhelming and intimidating aura that made her feel like a small, weak mortal every time she felt it.

"Having doubts? Second thoughts?" Satan spoke from behind her, his voice filled with amusement at the internal struggle even she must be madly coping with.

"I should think so." Keeping her voice even, Marie swallowed carefully. "Even the Jews that collaborated with the Nazis must have been filled with regrets. However, they were simply trying to save their own skin. As for myself..."

Satan snickered as he stared at the back of the tiny human in front of himself. "Yes, as for you, you're just a greedy soul looking out for number one. But I can understand the sentiment. The demons have become greedy, as have the gods and angels. I can't say I respect it, but I understand it."

Satan paced forwards a step or two until he was standing directly beside her. Her heart was pounding rapidly as his eyes flicked down to the screen. His tiny smile turned into a full bore grin as he saw her trembling hand hovering over the prompt onscreen. "Would you like for me to do it? I won't hold it against you if you want to back out now, but I'm going to do it one way or another."

"No. I'll do it. I just need a moment." Marie bit off each sentence harshly as she gritted her teeth. It wasn't easy, making a choice like this.

Her finger twitched as she lowered it down slowly, hesitantly. Finally, it was a hair's length above the screen.

She swallowed again, her dry throat giving her one last warning about the regrets she would be living with for the rest of her existence. "Well... here we go."

In the blink of an eye, she pressed her finger down the rest of the way, as 'YES' lit up on her screen.

An instant later, she exhaled deeply, realizing she had been holding her breath. It was over now. She wouldn't even know anything had happened, if it weren't for the monitoring room showing images of the world around her.

Turning to look at a monitor showing a local city in Kansas, tears filled her eyes as the camera began to shake.

"What have I done?"

Satan placed a hand on her shoulder, grinning evilly as he too watched the display.

"Exactly what you needed to do. With this, you have cemented yourself as a true ally of the demons."

* * *

A man pounded furiously on the door of the large estate, slapping the doorbell over and over again as rage and anger filled his mind. The rain outside was scheduled to end at precisely 4:30 AM, and it was 4:17 now. If he had just woken up a bit later, he might not be drenched to his bones.

But he didn't care. What was rain, compared to the lives of billions?

"Beatrix! Supreme commander Beatrix!!!" Kicking on the sturdy oak door, he pounded furiously until he finally heard a slow, hesitant unlocking of the door as a butler peeked out at the sopping wet man.

"Who are you? The lady of the house is sleeping right now. No visitors."

In a flash, the man shoved the door aside, pushing the butler out of the way as he stormed past. "To hell with sleep! Have you not seen the news yet?!"

The butler, Alonso, glared madly at the crazed fool who had barged his way into the house. "My word! If you don't get off the premises immediately, I will call security! You deranged madman!"

The man turned and blasted a fiery hot glare of rage and annoyance at the butler. "You idiot! The world is under attack! Get Beatrix down here now!"

Alonso gazed at the man's disheveled appearance, suddenly feeling a note of incredulity in his voice. "Ben Brown? You're the one who..." Realizing suddenly who the man was, Alonso suddenly felt his heart slamming in his chest. If the great Benjamin Brown was this angry, it must be serious.

"I'll wake her at once. Follow me."

* * *

Beatrix stood stiffly in her room, watching the newscast scrolling over her screen, shock having overtaken her body and paralyzed her with a feeling of hopelessness, as the reports came in. North America was effectively gone. Canada, the States, and even half of South America too. The tremors and volcanoes had sprung up out of nowhere. Ash was rapidly filling the atmosphere.

Already reports were coming in on her private military data feed. The ash cloud was set to spread over the entire planet within a day or two. Only the weather control systems would be any use in slowing it down. The first volcano, at the epicenter of all these calamities, had exploded out of nowhere with the force of Krakatoa from the 1800's. Its power was unrivaled and an incredible expression of the forces belonging to Mother Nature.

For sure, this was no mere weather phenomenon. This was not the result of plates shifting or random tectonic forces converging.

This was an attack.

Was it the Volgrim? Of course it was.

As she stared limply at the reports scrolling in, her bedroom door was suddenly thrown open, as her butler rushed in, followed by a familiar looking man she had not seen in a few years. His sopping wet body might have made it difficult to tell who he was, but his bulky and toned body, black skin, and trademark purple uniform gave him away at once.

"Beatrix! You're awake?" Ben Brown breathed rapidly as he glanced first from her, to the holoscreen on the wall, then to the pad in her hands. She knew.

"Yes. I'm awake." Beatrix spoke haltingly. She was feeling a rush of emotions she had not felt in a long time as the realization of what had happened was setting in.

"It's an attack by the Volgrim, doubtlessly." Ben calmed down as he took in Beatrix's figure, standing there proudly, concealing her emotions so as to keep her subordinates calm in the face of danger. A true commander, of course.

"Yes. An attack." Beatrix felt her grip tightening on the datapad in her hands as she stared, not *at* Ben, but past him, far past him into an unseen void. "I was a fool."

Ben's expression turned into confusion. "Huh? What are you talking about?"

"Peace. I wanted peace. I wanted peace with these aliens. I wanted peace with them, because I don't like war." Beatrix turned her empty gaze towards the casualty reports on her screen. "And look what it got me."

Ben stared carefully at the commander's face, as he took a few steps towards her. "Supreme commander, this isn't your fault. We need you at the headquarters, it's chaos down there."

"What would you know." Beatrix punctuated her question rhetorically, indicating it was a statement.

Ben froze as he stopped walking towards her. Something about her demeanor... "Commander, are you alri-"

"I SAID WHAT WOULD YOU KNOW?!" Beatrix snapped, throwing her datapad to the ground and stomping in with her right foot as a flash of hot fury exploded inside of her. Ben and Alonso jumped back at the sight of the usually reserved woman exploded in rage. "I tried to negotiate with these fucking monsters for more than fifty years! LOOK WHAT IT GOT ME!"

Howling at the top of her lungs, Beatrix turned to her bedside dresser and overturned it, throwing it to the ground as she started smashing everything she could get her hands on. Tearing off a leg from a table sitting against the wall, she used the leg to start smashing everything in the room as tears of rage poured down her face.

Ben and Alonso stood back, not in fear, but out of sorrow. The pain she felt must have been...

After a minute or two of tearing around the room, destroying every damned thing in sight, Beatrix seemed to suddenly calm down as she slumped to the floor, tears pouring down her face as she wiped them away furiously with both hands. "Fuck! Shit! It's not right! It's just not right!"

Ben walked forwards but kept his distance from her as he knelt down to her level. "This isn't your fault, commander. This is *their* fault."

"It's not that! It's... my family... they were visiting the East Coast of America for Christmas. They're... they're..." She bit off her sentence as rage and sorrow overtook her. "My mother, and my father, and both of my sisters..."

Ben shimmied closer to her as he wrapped both arms around her. "I'm... I'm sorry commander. I lost some family too, I think. I don't know, I'm just not thinking about it right now. We all deal with it in different ways."

Beatrix slowly stopped babbling as she succumbed to grief for a minute or two. Finally, she furiously wiped away her tears as she stood up slowly, pulling herself up by the edge of the bed.

Rising to her full height, she stood only a few inches shorter than Ben Brown, who was a tall and sturdy 6'5". The both of them looked quite intimidating as the sadness slowly melted away.

"Those... bastards." Beatrix felt a snarl curl up on her face as she wiped at her puffed and swollen eyes. "This is the final straw. Chancellor Brown, we're putting an end to all diplomacy. No more attempts at peace. No more idealistic notions or childhood fantasies. We're going to crush these invaders."

She glanced over at the holoscreen, as reports were coming in of Volgrim entering Europe and attacking several major cities.

Ben lowered his gaze as he felt the sudden alteration of the Supreme Commander, at her most base level. She had always been one of the most peace loving people, and now...

"As you will, Supreme Commander. Let's go, we can save the tears for later."

"Yes. Let's."

* * *

Marie stared with bewilderment at her screens. "Damn! The European device didn't activate! If we don't set it off, this will create one hell of a backlash!"

Satan felt emotions boiling through him as he stared at the small woman beside him. Was this intentional? Did she perhaps sabotage the second device? Nonsense, she wasn't even in Europe and hadn't inspected it. It couldn't have been her.

Of course it couldn't. This woman was ruthless. She was no friend of humanity.

Or was she?

Satan smoothed out his expression as she turned to look at him in bewilderment. Her confusion seemed genuine. It was probably just a glitch in the system. What else could have caused that device to misfire?

"It's fine. We weakened humanity severely. The Volgrim are already attacking the key cities as planned. The ash cloud will eventually cover Earth, even if we didn't take out the main technological centers in the other continents."

"It won't happen quickly, though, Satan. The weather control systems will be able to hold the cloud off for several weeks, possibly months. Not just enough time for an evacuation, but enough time to figure out a solution to remove the cloud."

Marie bit harshly onto her fingernails as she watched the numbers coming in. Actually, it was worse than expected. The Americas were important for humanity to develop new technology, but doubtlessly there were still many well-fortified bunkers built underground that had taken little damage. For one thing, Marie's own laboratory had likely survived just fine. What of the Type 3 Energy testing facilities? What about Jason Hiro's own underground bases?

Marie snarled. This was a terrible outcome. Not the worst, but bad. Still, if humanity should survive and rebuild, then she'd simply have to switch sides. Playing both sides of the field, that was what she excelled at. Much like the bankers during WWII, she got along with leaders for both teams, and they in return would not begrudge her if she made a quick buck, or if she simply saved her own skin.

Yes, in the end, it didn't matter who won. She would become one with the winner.

Still, who could have possibly sabotaged that device? It was protected by dozens of hundred digit codes. Simply unlocking the mainframe would take an ordinary person hours to get past the security. There was just no culprit, and it couldn't have been a simple misfiring.

Marie continued to gnaw at her finger as that question weighed on her mind.

Part 288a:

Marie's entire body was shaking as she stood silently in the Labyrinth. She was in a special room, built especially for her by Satan himself, using a lot of his innate energy and abilities.

The room was a large monitoring room, filled with wall-to-wall supercomputers and hundreds of monitors, used for monitoring the situation on Earth and plenty of other locations, such as the Moon and Mars, all at once. Dozens of imps moved around here and there, the smartest of their tiny brethren, but not much smarter than a very dull human.

Marie, however, was trembling noticeably as she held the datapad in her hands that would seal the fate of humanity. A command was sitting onscreen, prompting her to activate the doomsday device that would surely kill billions of people. She shook in fear of what was to come next, not because she feared humanity's response, or because she feared the demons if they were left to rule, but because she feared the *unknown*.

Humans, of course, always fear that which they do not understand. But nothing is less predictable and understandable than a tentative future turned into total chaos by one massive act of random destruction. Once she activated this prompt, everything would change. The balance of power would shift tremendously. Alliances would crumble and reform.

Marie, though, was even more fearful of the unknown. Her entire life rested on science, manipulation, and the act of reading and interpreting data. As a young girl, she had dreamed of total world domination, though she quickly grew out of that childhood farce. Growing older, she had discovered the existence of the demons by chance, and grew jealous of their awesome power as she learned more and more about them. Once again though, she realized attaining the power the demons possessed was physically impossible for her weak human body.

Still, she matured and her ambitions shifted goals again, now aimed towards her current goal, which was the advancement of science. No science in particular was her goal, though her body always quivered when it came to weapons of war. As a young girl, she had loved playing 'war' with her brothers, even if it wasn't a girly thing to do, and even as she aged, war was a fascinating topic for her.

And in the end, it was always men that died at war, not women. So if she were to stoke a major war somehow, it wouldn't affect her.

In the end, her brothers had died, along with the rest of her family, in a tragic house fire. The whole of her life had hardened her, leading her to the conclusion that life was unfair. There was

no justice in this world. The only way to win at life was to make herself as untouchable as possible. She would become so powerful that even the Creator would not be able to stop her.

* * *

Still, this act was unlike anything she had done in the past. One might even have, for a while, called her an ally of humanity. The anti-energy weapons she had taken from the Nazi research facilities had been used to create weapons that could eliminate the angels... or the demons. If they should turn against humanity, or herself, they would be driven back.

But now here she was, about to kill off billions of people. And she trembled... for nothing she would ever do for the rest of her life could possibly redeem her for this heinous act.

She felt a presence behind herself, a familiar overwhelming and intimidating aura that made her feel like a small, weak mortal every time she felt it.

"Having doubts? Second thoughts?" Satan spoke from behind her, his voice filled with amusement at the internal struggle even she must be madly coping with.

"I should think so." Keeping her voice even, Marie swallowed carefully. "Even the Jews that collaborated with the Nazis must have been filled with regrets. However, they were simply trying to save their own skin. As for myself..."

Satan snickered as he stared at the back of the tiny human in front of himself. "Yes, as for you, you're just a greedy soul looking out for number one. But I can understand the sentiment. The demons have become greedy, as have the gods and angels. I can't say I respect it, but I understand it."

Satan paced forwards a step or two until he was standing directly beside her. Her heart was pounding rapidly as his eyes flicked down to the screen. His tiny smile turned into a full bore grin as he saw her trembling hand hovering over the prompt onscreen. "Would you like for me to do it? I won't hold it against you if you want to back out now, but I'm going to do it one way or another."

"No. I'll do it. I just need a moment." Marie bit off each sentence harshly as she gritted her teeth. It wasn't easy, making a choice like this.

Her finger twitched as she lowered it down slowly, hesitantly. Finally, it was a hair's length above the screen.

She swallowed again, her dry throat giving her one last warning about the regrets she would be living with for the rest of her existence. "Well... here we go."

In the blink of an eye, she pressed her finger down the rest of the way, as 'YES' lit up on her screen.

An instant later, she exhaled deeply, realizing she had been holding her breath. It was over now. She wouldn't even know anything had happened, if it weren't for the monitoring room showing images of the world around her.

Turning to look at a monitor showing a local city in Kansas, tears filled her eyes as the camera began to shake.

"What have I done?"

Satan placed a hand on her shoulder, grinning evilly as he too watched the display.

"Exactly what you needed to do. With this, you have cemented yourself as a true ally of the demons."

* * *

A man pounded furiously on the door of the large estate, slapping the doorbell over and over again as rage and anger filled his mind. The rain outside was scheduled to end at precisely 4:30 AM, and it was 4:17 now. If he had just woken up a bit later, he might not be drenched to his bones.

But he didn't care. What was rain, compared to the lives of billions?

"Beatrix! Supreme commander Beatrix!!!" Kicking on the sturdy oak door, he pounded furiously until he finally heard a slow, hesitant unlocking of the door as a butler peeked out at the sopping wet man.

"Who are you? The lady of the house is sleeping right now. No visitors."

In a flash, the man shoved the door aside, pushing the butler out of the way as he stormed past. "To hell with sleep! Have you not seen the news yet?!"

The butler, Alonso, glared madly at the crazed fool who had barged his way into the house. "My word! If you don't get off the premises immediately, I will call security! You deranged madman!"

The man turned and blasted a fiery hot glare of rage and annoyance at the butler. "You idiot! The world is under attack! Get Beatrix down here now!"

Alonso gazed at the man's disheveled appearance, suddenly feeling a note of incredulity in his voice. "Ben Brown? You're the one who..." Realizing suddenly who the man was, Alonso suddenly felt his heart slamming in his chest. If the great Benjamin Brown was this angry, it must be serious.

"I'll wake her at once. Follow me."

* * *

Beatrix stood stiffly in her room, watching the newscast scrolling over her screen, shock having overtaken her body and paralyzed her with a feeling of hopelessness, as the reports came in. North America was effectively gone. Canada, the States, and even half of South America too. The tremors and volcanoes had sprung up out of nowhere. Ash was rapidly filling the atmosphere.

Already reports were coming in on her private military data feed. The ash cloud was set to spread over the entire planet within a day or two. Only the weather control systems would be any use in slowing it down. The first volcano, at the epicenter of all these calamities, had exploded out of nowhere with the force of Krakatoa from the 1800's. Its power was unrivaled and an incredible expression of the forces belonging to Mother Nature.

For sure, this was no mere weather phenomenon. This was not the result of plates shifting or random tectonic forces converging.

This was an attack.

Was it the Volgrim? Of course it was.

As she stared limply at the reports scrolling in, her bedroom door was suddenly thrown open, as her butler rushed in, followed by a familiar looking man she had not seen in a few years. His sopping wet body might have made it difficult to tell who he was, but his bulky and toned body, black skin, and trademark purple uniform gave him away at once.

"Beatrix! You're awake?" Ben Brown breathed rapidly as he glanced first from her, to the holoscreen on the wall, then to the pad in her hands. She knew.

"Yes. I'm awake." Beatrix spoke haltingly. She was feeling a rush of emotions she had not felt in a long time as the realization of what had happened was setting in.

"It's an attack by the Volgrim, doubtlessly." Ben calmed down as he took in Beatrix's figure, standing there proudly, concealing her emotions so as to keep her subordinates calm in the face of danger. A true commander, of course.

"Yes. An attack." Beatrix felt her grip tightening on the datapad in her hands as she stared, not *at* Ben, but past him, far past him into an unseen void. "I was a fool."

Ben's expression turned into confusion. "Huh? What are you talking about?"

"Peace. I wanted peace. I wanted peace with these aliens. I wanted peace with them, because I don't like war." Beatrix turned her empty gaze towards the casualty reports on her screen. "And look what it got me."

Ben stared carefully at the commander's face, as he took a few steps towards her. "Supreme commander, this isn't your fault. We need you at the headquarters, it's chaos down there."

"What would you know." Beatrix punctuated her question rhetorically, indicating it was a statement.

Ben froze as he stopped walking towards her. Something about her demeanor... "Commander, are you alri-"

"I SAID WHAT WOULD YOU KNOW?!" Beatrix snapped, throwing her datapad to the ground and stomping in with her right foot as a flash of hot fury exploded inside of her. Ben and Alonso jumped back at the sight of the usually reserved woman exploded in rage. "I tried to negotiate with these fucking monsters for more than fifty years! LOOK WHAT IT GOT ME!"

Howling at the top of her lungs, Beatrix turned to her bedside dresser and overturned it, throwing it to the ground as she started smashing everything she could get her hands on. Tearing off a leg from a table sitting against the wall, she used the leg to start smashing everything in the room as tears of rage poured down her face.

Ben and Alonso stood back, not in fear, but out of sorrow. The pain she felt must have been...

After a minute or two of tearing around the room, destroying every damned thing in sight, Beatrix seemed to suddenly calm down as she slumped to the floor, tears pouring down her face as she wiped them away furiously with both hands. "Fuck! Shit! It's not right! It's just not right!"

Ben walked forwards but kept his distance from her as he knelt down to her level. "This isn't your fault, commander. This is *their* fault."

"It's not that! It's... my family... they were visiting the East Coast of America for Christmas. They're... they're..." She bit off her sentence as rage and sorrow overtook her. "My mother, and my father, and both of my sisters..."

Ben shimmied closer to her as he wrapped both arms around her. "I'm... I'm sorry commander. I lost some family too, I think. I don't know, I'm just not thinking about it right now. We all deal with it in different ways."

Beatrix slowly stopped babbling as she succumbed to grief for a minute or two. Finally, she furiously wiped away her tears as she stood up slowly, pulling herself up by the edge of the bed.

Rising to her full height, she stood only a few inches shorter than Ben Brown, who was a tall and sturdy 6'5". The both of them looked quite intimidating as the sadness slowly melted away.

"Those... bastards." Beatrix felt a snarl curl up on her face as she wiped at her puffed and swollen eyes. "This is the final straw. Chancellor Brown, we're putting an end to all diplomacy. No more attempts at peace. No more idealistic notions or childhood fantasies. We're going to crush these invaders."

She glanced over at the holoscreen, as reports were coming in of Volgrim entering Europe and attacking several major cities.

Ben lowered his gaze as he felt the sudden alteration of the Supreme Commander, at her most base level. She had always been one of the most peace loving people, and now...

"As you will, Supreme Commander. Let's go, we can save the tears for later."

"Yes. Let's."

* * *

Marie stared with bewilderment at her screens. "Damn! The European device didn't activate! If we don't set it off, this will create one hell of a backlash!"

Satan felt emotions boiling through him as he stared at the small woman beside him. Was this intentional? Did she perhaps sabotage the second device? Nonsense, she wasn't even in Europe and hadn't inspected it. It couldn't have been her.

Of course it couldn't. This woman was ruthless. She was no friend of humanity.

Or was she?

Satan smoothed out his expression as she turned to look at him in bewilderment. Her confusion seemed genuine. It was probably just a glitch in the system. What else could have caused that device to misfire?

"It's fine. We weakened humanity severely. The Volgrim are already attacking the key cities as planned. The ash cloud will eventually cover Earth, even if we didn't take out the main technological centers in the other continents."

"It won't happen quickly, though, Satan. The weather control systems will be able to hold the cloud off for several weeks, possibly months. Not just enough time for an evacuation, but enough time to figure out a solution to remove the cloud."

Marie bit harshly onto her fingernails as she watched the numbers coming in. Actually, it was worse than expected. The Americas were important for humanity to develop new technology, but doubtlessly there were still many well-fortified bunkers built underground that had taken little damage. For one thing, Marie's own laboratory had likely survived just fine. What of the Type 3 Energy testing facilities? What about Jason Hiro's own underground bases?

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Part 289a:

An explosion. A flash of bright light. The sound of metal smashing into metal, as teams of titanic warriors careened into each other.

A little boy watched from a nearby window, his body shaking half in terror, half in amazement at the battle he was witnessing. He was just an orphan, left behind in the rush of the evacuation, nobody had bothered to look for him. He was one of the forgotten.

But that was all right, he liked playing action and adventure simulations, this was like one of those on steroids.

Two of the hypersuit commandos and a tiny little girl were fighting a massive robot, its spider-like appearance and huge size belying its incredible speed and power. It looked big and bulky, as if it were a slow shambling thing, but its 360 degree area of sight meant once it locked onto its targets, it never lost track of their positions. Each of its four arms moved independently, fighting off each assailant with ease. Just when each attacker thought they had gained ground against it, the automaton would then pull out a new trick.

This young orphan, Ricky, especially kept his eye on the little girl. From his vantage point only a few feet up in the air, less than a couple blocks away, he couldn't make out any of their words as they attacked, as the impacts of their weapons lit up the usually quiet and reserved neighborhood. The little girl took a terrible blow to her body, sending her sprawling backwards a few dozen feet as she smashed into the brick base of another building. The impact should surely have killed her unarmored self, but she quickly got up and dusted herself off, rushing back in to do her part.

She seemed very strong, easily capable of fighting equally among the other two armored warriors. Of course, Ricky, like all kids, knew who the Hypersuit Commandos were. He wanted to join them when he grew up, as they were the coolest soldiers in the universe. Most kids wanted to, and he had planned to trick out his very own hypersuit once he had one of his own.

But Ricky wasn't dumb. He knew that the latest series of events were bad, really bad. His friends had panicked when they heard about the volcanoes and the earthquakes, but Ricky had faith in humanity's power. Was he forgotten by the others when they fled? Perhaps he'd hidden himself, just so he could watch.

That's just the sort of kid he was.

* * *

Amelia wiped a tiny bit of blood from her mouth. The impact had hit much harder than she expected, causing even her incredibly resistant body to take some damage. It was likely an internal injury, but Leviathan would take care of it given a bit of rest later on.

"Princess, you don't need to be here. You don't need to fight alongside a *hero*."

Leviathan murmured inside her ear but she shook her head quickly. "I'm not doing this because I have to, Levvy!"

Running forwards, she grabbed a signpost and ripped it out of the ground in one smooth motion, as she jumped up and grabbed onto one of the mecha's legs. Wrapping her small body around the relatively thin leg, she used the sign-pole as a weapon and stabbed straight forwards, the sign facing heavy resistance but still piercing through the leg all the way through the other side. Just as she finished, the robot flicked one of its four arms around and slapped her from its leg, knocking her a few feet away as she came to a rolling stop. Shambling back up to her feet, she rubbed her arm and winced as she felt a bruise developing.

Jason was busy fighting the robot in his own way, but he seemed to be frustrated about something, as if he had expected the fight to be super easy, yet now it was much more difficult than expected. Jamming his armored hand into the side of a building, he tore out a huge chunk of brick and stone and chucked it with explosive speed at the mecha, the block smashing into the cybernetic being with incredible force, a loud shock-wave blasting from it as the debris blew up into tiny fragments and split all over the place, embedding themselves in walls and the ground.

"Princess, this *thing* is not going down easily. Whatever it's made of, best to just leave it to the hero and his comrade. This isn't our battle." Leviathan again urged her to leave, as he had been fighting her for the last couple months to abandon Jason and go back to her usual self.

Amelia wasn't having any of it. "Levvy, you're usually such a sweetheart, but for once, just let me think for myself! This is fun! I like fighting something that takes real effort to take down!"

"I'm not talking about the battle, princess. I'm talking about your associating with a *hero*. You know what they mean, you know what he will do to you later on, correct? He's your enemy. You can't trust him."

"I-I know that much!" Amelia glared at nothing in particular as she once again felt annoyance at the dragon inside of herself. Jason had taken a few steps back from the battle while his gold and black armored friend pressed the assault. Glancing over at Amelia as she seemed to talk with herself again, he barely seemed to give her a passing thought as he jumped back into the fray.

Amelia glowered as she stumbled forwards slightly, a sudden stinging pain in her chest caught her off guard as she wheezed for breath.

"Princess, you were hit by some of that shrapnel. It's jammed into your chest. Pull it out so I can heal you."

Amelia glanced down with alarm as she saw blood sprouting from a freshly opened wound, as indeed there were two or three small pieces of rock and brick embedded into her sternum. The wounds weren't deep enough to badly wound her, but they certainly *hurt*, and she wasn't used to feeling pain.

Quickly pulling them out, she waited for Leviathan to heal her but paused as the blood continued to slowly leak from the wound. "Levy, what's wrong? Why aren't you healing me?"

Frustration crept into her friend's voice. "I can't. There's some sort of energy hampering my abilities. I have been wondering about this for a while now, but there's no way you should be having trouble against that monster. It's putting off some kind of spiritual energy nullifier, and your abilities are greatly weakened as a result."

Amelia flicked her eyes up at the eight legged monstrosity. *So that was it.* "Alright, if I get further away, will you be able to heal me?"

Leviathan grunted quietly. "Yes, princess. I believe that will do. But you also need to revitalize yourself. You haven't had a meal in a long time, you know. You have to take care of yourself."

Amelia gritted her teeth. "Yes, Levy. I know. I... know."

Reluctantly, she quickly started moving away from the fight, slowly feeling as if a weight upon her body was lessening the further away from the robot that she got.

I'm sorry, Jason. You'll have to forgive me for leaving you like this.

As she left the scene of the fight, Amelia felt something that she couldn't remember feeling ever before. It was a feeling that, if she were a girl of moral stature, she might liken the feeling to *guilt*.

Once she was a few blocks away, she began to feel her wound rapidly healing as Leviathan quickly began to work his regeneration abilities on her. In seconds, she felt whole again.

"There, you're healed. Now, while the hero isn't looking, you need to find sustenance."

Amelia felt a sudden rush of hormones flood her mind as her vision dipped in and out for a moment or two. Stumbling forwards, she felt greatly weakened as her mouth dried up in an instant. "Ahhh... Levy, I don't feel so good..."

"That's expected. I used your own dwindling energy to heal you. You *have* to feed."

Tilting her head back, Amelia listened to the sounds of combat in the distance, as Jason didn't appear to be following her. She had moved far away from the main action with the Volgrim and humans, so she didn't have any aliens or demons to eat...

Her eyes flicked around as she quickly looked for heat signatures. Up, in a nearby window, she spotted a small child watching the battle with a simple-minded curiosity.

Pushing her guilt aside, Amelia licked her lips as she made her move.

* * *

I was moving very sluggishly for some reason. Usually, a battle with any being, even a strong one like this, would be over in a flash. More disturbingly, I realized early on that my wordsmithing was not only ineffective against it, but I was unable to use my wordsmithing at all while in its presence.

"Centurion, is there any form of energy dampening in the immediate area?"

Amelia had run off a few minutes ago. Likely, seeing the wound she had sustained, even she was having trouble fighting this robot.

"AFFIRMATIVE, PILOT JASON HERO! SUIT STABILITY IS DOWN TO 50%! OVERALL COMBAT EFFECTIVENESS HAS DROPPED BY 85% FROM NORMAL EXPECTED PARAMETERS! A TACTICAL RETREAT IS RECOMMENDED!"

I gritted my teeth as the massive Dragoon smashed me with its massive blunt weapon, a hammer-like object with a heavy round head that weighed several times what the rest of the entire pole combined did. It was very dense, easily capable of leveling a skyscraper given a few aimed hits.

"I can't retreat, Centurion! If Ben and I don't take this thing out, it'll continue killing more and more people! Give me options!"

A sudden flash of movement had me grimace as Ben, even with his highly enhanced abilities thanks to a direct neural connection with his suit, was flattened into the ground by one blow of the mecha's hammer.

"TYPE 3 ENERGY IS BEING DAMPENED IN THIS UNIT'S IMMEDIATE VICINITY. CONVENTIONAL WEAPONRY IS HIGHLY ADVISED AGAINST THIS OPPONENT. WOULD YOU LIKE TO ACTIVATE PHASE MODE?"

There it was again, 'Phase Mode'. It was supposed to be a crazy trump card, though I wasn't sure just how effective it would be in this situation. I had barely even used it in the fight against Amelia.

"Yes, activate Phase Mode. Let's see what it can do."

"AFFIRMATIVE, PILOT JASON HIRO. HYPER DEFENSES NOW ONLINE. WARNING! SUIT STABILITY IS AT 45%! HYPER DEFENSES ARE UNTESTED AT THIS STABILITY THRESHOLD! USE CAUTION, PILOT JASON HIRO!"

I suddenly felt my body stiffen as a humming feeling could be detected all over inside the suit. Just as I was questioning what that humming meant, I looked up just in time to see a hovercar flying directly at me. With no time to dodge, I flinched as I raised a hand up to try and catch it.

Instead, I was suddenly dumbfounded as the car sailed directly through my body, passing through me as if I wasn't even there.

Feeling astonished at what had just happened, I blurted out a few words in confusion. "What the hell just happened?!"

"IN PHASE MODE, RATHER THAN ABSORBING AN IMPACT DIRECTLY, THE HYPERSUIT VIBRATES AT SPEEDS FAST ENOUGH TO PHASE THROUGH OBJECTS. IN TERMS OF DEFENSE, WHAT CANNOT HIT YOU WILL NOT BE ABLE TO HURT YOU."

Centurion, of course, already had a response prepared. I nodded slowly as I realized that I was sitting around gawking while Ben fought the Dragoon all by himself. I felt like my body's sluggishness had also faded somewhat as well, as I charged forwards, jumping up into the air, I phased through the Dragoon as it swung at me. As the arm swung through me, the Dragoon experienced an apparent moment of confusion as its arm instead smashed into a building instead of me. Flying forwards, I phased through its main upper body, my body solidifying once inside of it, as I started kicking and punching rapidly, tearing it to pieces from the inside out.

Interestingly, there was very little wiring, and this appeared to be a half biological weapon, possibly created by the Volgrim in some weird test tube laboratory somewhere until it reached this monstrous size. While inside of the tight cramped space inside of it, I kicked off hard from against its inner body, blasting out of its back as oddly colored innards spilled out onto the street below.

Landing on the ground with a thud, I rolled myself quickly back into a standing position and looked back, just in time to see the Dragoon fumbling around trying to steady itself as it lost more and more of its inner parts all over the street. Finally, with a single forward stagger, the Dragoon stumbled forwards and slumped to the ground, dead.

I stared for several seconds as I breathed heavily, more out of adrenaline than out of fear or excitement. Ben quickly jumped over, landing beside me in one smooth motion. His suit appeared to be in good condition, but his voice was hoarse and choked, as if he had been

physically injured. Popping his helmet open, I saw his face was contorted into an expression of pain. "Hah... good job, Judicator. I don't know how you did it, but you managed... to take that piece of shit down." He coughed quickly as blood spilled from his mouth on the street. After choking for a second or two, he regained his composure, as I quickly used " **Heal.** " on him.

After regaining his breath, he half grinned, half grimaced at me. "That ain't the only one though. Think you've got another one of those fights left in you?"

I quickly shook my head as I activated my outwards speakers. "No. We're going to need a new tactic to deal with those. Their energy dampening is..." I paused, realizing what I almost said. "...well, it's not easy to deal with."

He flicked an eyebrow up. "Energy dampening? What do you mean?"

I quickly came up with a half baked lie. "Didn't you notice your suit performing worse than usual? The suits use exotic energy to power themselves. If they can dampen the suit's powers, these battles aren't quite so one sided anymore."

Ben gnawed on his teeth as he turned away, reaching up to stroke his bushy mustache. "Damn. I knew these suits wouldn't be the ultimate weapon forever. Sooner or later they were going to come up with a counter for them."

I nodded quietly. Actually, I had the oddest feeling that neither demon nor Volgrim had anything to do with these energy dampeners. Every bone in my body screamed this was a homegrown culprit, and I even had a small idea of who might be behind it.

I paused for several seconds as I found my mind racing. I jerked my head up, quickly scanning the area.

Where did Amelia go?

Part 290a: Hunger

Amelia entered the building where the young child in the window was hiding. He had seen her walking in and had waved at her. She didn't wave back.

Her head pounded as her chest tightened. She had never gone this long without a meal. It had been at least four months. Well beyond the limits of a normal human, but she might have gone on for much longer, were it not for the fact that the battle had wounded her so badly.

She walked up the stairs quickly at first, then gradually she slowed her pace as doubt entered her mind. This was a bad thing to do. It was very bad. Jason wouldn't like it. Levvy was her friend, but Jason was too. Jason always looked sad, like he didn't like punching her that first time. He always seemed to feel guilty around her. Jason wasn't like other humans.

As she walked up the stairs, she turned around a corner, arriving at the third floor. Only two more floors to go, and she would be where that young boy was.

Her stomach growled as Leviathan spoke quietly in your mind. "Princess, I feel your doubt. But you mustn't hesitate. Time is of the essence."

She felt a frown appear on her face, an expression she had rarely made before. "Levvy... what will happen if I... don't eat him?"

A tinge of irritation appeared in her mind as Leviathan seemed to grumble quietly. "You will very likely die, princess."

"I'll die, huh?" Amelia cringed as a wave of hunger surged over her body again, taking over her senses for a few moments. It was a feeling she had experienced countless times over thousands of years, and one she had nearly forgotten about.

But until now, Amelia had never doubted the Hunger. It had been a part of her for as long as she had remembered. With the effort most people took to take a bite of a sandwich, she had never taken a second thought for devouring another life whole.

And now she did.

Finally, she arrived on the fifth floor, her body sensing the presence of the tiny life form on the other side of a door leading into one of the rooms. This appeared to be a cheap motel, a place for tourists to arrive at. Why had a small child been left here, all alone?

Amelia shook the thoughts from her head. It didn't matter. He was just a meal. Just... a thing to sustain her. He was just a lump of meat, no emotion was needed to process sustenance.

As she walked up to the door, her heart skipped a beat as the door was suddenly yanked open. There stood the little boy, a big smile on his face as he looked her up and down. "Hi! I'm Ricky! What's your name?"

She swallowed involuntarily, caught totally off guard by his offputting jovial smile. "My name, it's uh... Amelia."

He took two quick steps over to her, making her flinch backwards a step or two. Quickly he ran behind her and nodded vigorously. "Wow! I like your dress! You're so pretty, Amelia!"

Looking to be only ten or eleven years old himself, Amelia realized that with her youthful appearance, he must think she was his own age.

"I saw you out there fighting that big robot. You looked so cool, wow!" He grabbed her by the hand, pulling her into the room as he quickly closed the door behind them. "Come on in, have a seat! Do you want anything to eat?"

Amelia jerked her head back at the question. She licked her lips as another pang of hunger struck her. Shoving it down with willpower alone, she merely nodded weakly.

Ricky was all too happy to oblige. He blushed as he turned away from her. She suddenly realized with a start that he might even have a crush on her. He was an interesting child.

"We don't have a lot to eat, just a baloney sandwich. Is that all right?" He walked over to the fridge without waiting for a response, pulling out some bread and meat as well as a small assortment of dressings and lettuce. He was really going all-out for this sandwich. "You look like you're starving!"

Amelia nodded weakly as she suddenly felt tears welling up in her eyes. While he wasn't looking, she turned away from him and quickly wiped them away. Why was she crying? This wasn't something she would usually show any emotions about.

"Y-yes... I'm very, very hungry..." Amelia bit off the words as she swallowed heavily. She gripped her stomach, looking at the boy, then to the ground, and back again.

A war raged in her mind. Countless battles and struggles she had never faced over the course of the last few thousand years inserted themselves viciously into her head in a way they had never done so before.

Leviathan spoke to her from deep within her heart. "Princess, why do you hesitate? You must live on. You cannot go on living like this. If you do not feed... you will..." Leviathan's voice trailed off as Amelia realized he too was feeling emotions of his own. *Sadness*. She was Leviathan's only friend, just as he had been her only friend, for thousands of years. The thought of her dying must be causing him to experience a tremendous sadness.

"I'm sorry, I just... can't..." Amelia whispered quietly, but realized she was once again speaking out loud. Ricky stood over at the counter, slapping together a baloney sandwich that would inspire awe all throughout the ages.

Ricky shot a glance over at her, as he finished up the final steps for the sandwich. "What was that? Did you need something else?"

Bouncing over to her, he quickly placed the sandwich in front of her, set on a very nice looking china plate. Bopping over to the other side of the table, he smiled and nodded vigorously. "Go on! I made it myself!"

Amelia felt a tiny smile creep onto her face. *Of course he made it himself, silly boy.*

She felt the smile vanish as a sullen expression passed over her face. She stared down at the sandwich for a long few moments, as Ricky's own smile began to fade as well.

"What's the matter? Did I not make it good enough?" Ricky's face appeared crestfallen as he stared at the pretty young girl sitting across from himself. He had never been one to like girls before, but he could just tell at a single glance, this girl was special. She wasn't like all the other ones. She was fighting with the Hypersuit Commandos, that made her really cool, almost one of the boys, but prettier!

Amelia shook her head slowly. "I'm hungry... but not for a sandwich..." Her voice cracked slightly as she felt her body start to shake. She slowly looked up from the bread and meat to look at the boy sitting across from her. He appeared very sad that she wasn't just going to eat the food he had made. In truth, normal food was revolting to her. Human flesh and its inherent properties was the only thing she was able to live on anymore.

She slowly stood up from her seat as Ricky's eyes followed her. "What do you mean? I can't make anything but a sandwich..."

She took a step towards him, and then another step, as she felt her entire body beginning to tremble.

Ricky quickly noticed the trembling. "Hey... Amelia... you don't look all right..."

She began to feel tears well up as she took another step towards him. "I'm sorry... I'm sorry... I'm sorry..." She whispered quietly as she felt her vision beginning to darken.

It was all right. It would be over in a second. He was just one boy. This was just one small bad thing, in the grand scheme of the entire world.

Suddenly, the door smashed open and Amelia's eyes popped open as she felt her vision clearing.

"Amelia! Get away from him!"

A familiar figure stood in the doorway. Jason Hiro, Amelia's second, most precious friend, watched her with his hollow metallic mask, as he took notice of the distance she had closed between her and the small boy.

"Whoa! A Hypersuit Commando! That's so cool!" Ricky grinned madly at the man in the doorway, oblivious to what the man had just said.

Amelia felt her trembling increase as Ricky ran right past her to the man in the doorway. "I love you guys! I'm gonna be a commando when I grow up too!" As he hopped and jumped excitedly, Jason carefully inserted himself between Amelia and the little boy.

"Yeah. That's real swell, kid. Hey, my other friend, the other commando, he's downstairs. You wanna go say hi to him?"

Ricky nodded viciously. "You mean Ben Brown?! Oh my god, he's the bestest of all the commandos in the world! Wow!!!" Without waiting another moment, Ricky raced off down the stairs.

Jason stared after the kid for a long few moments before turning his gaze back to the little girl in the room. "Amelia. What were you about to do?"

Amelia felt her lip quivering as her knees started to shake. "I'm... I'm sorry, Jason. I just... I was so... hungry... and I couldn't... I couldn't..." The guilt, combined with the realization she had betrayed her friend, caused something to break in her mind as she fell to the ground sobbing. "I didn't want to! I didn't want to do it, Jason."

Jason nodded quietly as he reached up and took his helmet off. Walking over he leaned down to the girl weeping on the floor. "Amelia. You didn't do it. The old you, the one I know of from the future... you wouldn't have hesitated. You were holding yourself back, weren't you?"

Amelia nodded quickly as she viciously wiped tears from her face. "I'm sorry! I didn't mean to hurt our trust!"

Jason frowned as he stared down at the small girl. *This is odd.*

* * *

I stayed and spoke with Amelia for several long minutes. She was not acting right. This was certainly a good way to act, but it felt so forced... as if she were acting like she betrayed me, but more importantly, *as if it mattered to her*. Did I matter to her? We'd barely known each other four months, in her frame of mind. How could she possibly take me at face value when I called her a friend?

I reached down and hugged her quietly as she sobbed in my arms. In my entire life, I had probably seen a few girls, even a few guys cry. But never like this. She was acting as if her best

friend had just committed a double murder suicide with her beloved parents, but all that had happened was she nearly devoured a small child. What the hell was this about?

Finally, the tears seemed to ebb and I stood up, watching her silently. She continued making choked noises as she wiped her face down with her hands. She merely stared at the floor, her emotions drained.

"I..."

Amelia spoke a single word, but didn't continue. I waited patiently, but after a full minute, she said nothing else.

Taking a seat at the table, I continued to keep a careful eye on her. "Amelia... it's time you told me. I want to know. Why do you need to eat people? Tell me, and maybe I can help."

Amelia continued to stare numbly at the ground. She never raised her gaze up for even a second. Seconds turned into another minute or two as my patience began wearing thin. "All right. If you won't tell me that, then tell me this... who is 'Levvy'?"

Instantly her head jerked up as her sad expression morphed into one of anger. "How do you know that name?"

She stood up quickly as she seemed to look me up and down. I shrugged nonchalantly as I kept a careful watch on her. "You talk to yourself, you know. A lot. And oftentimes, you say that name. Is he your friend?"

Her expression turned into an outright glare as she began to bore figurative holes in my chest with her eyes. "That's not your business. Don't pry where you don't belong."

She started to say something else but a look of irritation passed over her face as she turned away from me, almost seeming to listen to someone else speaking in the room. However, there was nobody else in here. It must be 'Levvy' again.

It was really beginning to bother me. Something told me that 'Levvy' wasn't a fiction of her imagination. She wasn't going crazy. She might actually be bipolar, but this seemed all too real. It wasn't the work of a second personality or voices in her head, but perhaps there was another being inside of her, much like how Satan had Hades inside of himself.

Speaking of which, I really ought to look into that some time. That might prove useful to find out about...

Amelia turned back to me and glowered slightly, before her eyes lowered again as her expression softened. "Ah, well... you don't mean any harm by it, I suppose. Still... maybe he's right. Maybe I should tell you. Not much you could do about it anyway."

I cocked an eyebrow at her sudden mental pivot. She really was an interesting character. "You'll tell me?"

She swallowed carefully as her eyes hesitantly met mine. "Yes. I have... someone inside of me. A dear friend. But, because of how he came to be inside of me, he causes... problems. It's not his fault. He means well..."

Her voice faltered momentarily as she blushed. "The Hunger is a side effect, a symptom if you will. Still, when I'm around you, like now... I barely even feel it. I wonder why that is..."

I blinked slowly and deliberately. "The 'hunger', huh? You've mentioned it a few times now. Is this why you, err, devour people? Because of your friend? Is he making you do it?"

Amelia quickly shook her head. "No! He causes me to crave what I need to survive, but only because of his... power. It's too much for my body. Yet, if he were to leave me, I would suddenly die of old age. He extends my life infinitely beyond normal lengths, but also changes who I am, fundamentally."

She was speaking very eloquently, all of a sudden. I wondered silently what caused these changes to her personality. Perhaps the more she ate, the crazier and more immature she acted, but the less she did, the more rapidly she aged? There were many possibilities, and I didn't know enough about her condition to perform a diagnosis.

I put my helmet back on after a few moments of contemplation, my speakers firing up as I stood up from my seat and tilted my head at her. "If it's simply a matter of not feeling hungry, perhaps I might be able to help. We're friends, Amelia. You should rely on me more. That is what friends do."

Turning my speakers off, I quickly wordsmithed the most relevant word I could think of. "**Satiate.**"

Amelia suddenly perked up, as her mental presence snapped back to fully alert. Blinking twice, she glanced down at her hands. "What...? Did you just do something?"

I shrugged as my speakers turned back on. "Maybe I did, maybe I didn't. Come on, we need to get out of here. Ben is waiting for us patiently. We need to clear out the Volgrim and others in the area."

Amelia turned and looked back at me. "I don't think I'll be much use against another one of those robots. You should just go on ahead without me."

I shook my head. "No, just come with me. I've been working on a new plan for dealing with them, and you're needed for it."

She cocked an eyebrow at my statement as an amused smile crossed her face. "Oh? Is that so?"

* * *

Beatrix bobbed her head up and down slowly as the man on the line spoke. "Listen, 'Silver', I understand you think this is important, but this all sounds like gobbledygook to me. I've got men dying on the battlefield as we speak. This all sounds like a bunch of gibberish. And do you really expect me to believe *magic* really exists?"

Silver sighed heavily as his holo-figure lowered his head. "I know it might sound crazy, but I've been working with these concepts my entire life. You do know who I am, don't you? I saved your life during Earth's Last Stand, where my Sword of Damocles prototype blasted dozens of enemy ships out of the air in minutes. The energy principles behind it were aided with the help of magical energy. This is no hoax, I'm being genuine."

Beatrix scowled as she heard an alarm sound off across the room. Another platoon was wiped out by the new mechas the Volgrim were deploying. "Silver, just keep this information to yourself for a while, alright? We can talk about this after I manage to scrub a few million alien parasitic scum off the face of the Earth, alright?"

Silver returned the expression. "No, this is the perfect time. If we start injecting soldiers, we'll have an army that can easily take on the Vol-"

Beatrix groaned as she pressed the 'end call' button, his voice being cut off mid sentence. *Leave it to men to go charging in with their dicks swinging and their minds silent.* She didn't have time for theoretical games about giving magical powers to humans. It was just a stupid thoughtless concept in the first place. Better to stick with tried-and-true battle tactics. That was how she won all her fights.

As she stood up and walked back over to the War Table, one thought crossed her mind. *Well, except that time Silver did save my ass with his cannons. Maybe I should have listened a little more carefully...*

Brushing the thought aside, she began barking orders to various ensigns and officers as she quickly took back control of the battlefield.

* * *

Silver slumped back in his seat as the Bitch of Britannia cut him off mid sentence. His assistant, Noah, handed him a fresh cup of coffee. Silver sighed as he took a long sip of it. "This is why I hate women. So illogical."

Noah nodded as he ignored his boss's comment. "Perhaps, sir, you're trying to go about this the wrong way."

Silver glanced back at the kid and smirked. "Oh really? You have a better idea, then?"

Noah shrugged. "You can't exactly go over her head, but maybe you can find someone else who will give you the go ahead. Someone who doesn't see eye to eye with the current Supreme Commander. Someone willing to give our idea a chance."

Agent Silver sighed quietly. "President Johannesburg was on to something when he told me to keep an eye on our 'Hero' friend. Jason is no ally of humanity. He had contact with Marie Becker, and he's probably working with her. Our list of possible contacts who will be against Marie and Jason is... small."

Noah nodded. "Well, I did take the liberty to search for a few. Maybe it will help you narrow down a target?"

Silver felt a massive grin take over his face as he scratched his aptly-colored silver hair. "You're not like my previous assistants, you're actually on the ball all the time."

"I try to be. Oh, and what happened to your previous assistants?"

Silver took another long swig of coffee. "They *weren't* on the ball. Show me the names of these contacts. We don't have much time."

Noah nodded as he reached into his pocket and pulled out a carefully folded piece of paper, with a mere four names and faces on it, followed by brief bios for each person.

Silver grunted as he took the paper and scanned it quickly. "This it?"

Noah nodded reluctantly. "Yes. But really, there's only one good name on that list. It's this man." He pointed at a rugged looking man, the first one on the list. "They call him 'Stonewall' in the military. He's only two notches below Beatrix, but he is well known for butting heads with her. His real name is Vasily Sokolov, but nobody would ever dare call him that to his face."

"Sokolov... sounds familiar." Silver stared carefully at the face. A massive hulking mountain of a man, Stonewall was listed as 7'8" tall, wore a trademark black suit, and always had his jet black hair smoothed down, in a sort of respectable mafia-boss sort of look. He led the Space Marines corps and had full authority over them, other than Beatrix herself.

"His name should. He's the grandson of Russia's prime minister from the turn of the century. He's a very terrifying man in person, and he carries himself like a leader. In fact, some would call him the antithesis of Beatrix herself. He hates 'Judicator' and thinks he's a menace to society, but above all else, he hates the Volgrim. He wants to purge their kind from the universe."

Silver nodded slowly as a smile crept back onto his face. "As he should. He would make for a fine puppet. His head is empty enough that a few half truths will have him sending the hounds wherever we direct."

Noah wandered over and plunked down into a sofa across the room. " *Nova Imperium*. A new government, under us. Well, not exactly under us, so to say, even we have someone to answer to. But close enough."

Silver shrugged. "We don't have to tell the Organization everything. The Illuminati is only as all seeing and all knowing as its members allow it to be, and we're pretty close to the top. Let's just keep this between us."

Noah nodded quietly. "Yes. Let's."

Part 291a: Lance

When we arrived downstairs, I noted with a glance downwards that Amelia was feeling uneasy and guilty towards Ricky, but he was completely oblivious. I observed Ben glancing uneasily out the window as Ricky babbled excitedly about how badly he wanted to be a Hypersuit Commando. The kid's excitement, while amusing, was also not the sort of thing Ben really cared about at that moment.

Sounds of destruction could be heard in the distance, and Ben didn't like having to babysit while his men were being killed on the frontlines. A quick glance at the casualty reports scrolling on the far side of my HUD told me what I needed to know; this battle was not going well for humanity. We were losing badly.

Ben's unease seemed to slip away slightly when he saw us walking down the stairs. "Good. You're done having a chit-chat session. I need to get back on the field."

I shook my head. "No. Not yet. Ben, Amelia and I are going to return to the battle. Take this kid back to the evacuation zone, then return here."

Ben gawked at me for a second before reigning in his shocked expression. "Judicator, I know you're an important asset to humanity, and one who has helped us greatly against the Volgrim, but you're not my commanding officer. Not anymore. I can't leave my men out there to die while you and the..." He paused as he glanced down at Amelia. "...You know, actually, this is bugging me. What the hell is this little girl made of? She was fighting on par with us battle hardened warriors as if she were wearing a Hypersuit... yet she wears no suit herself. What's going on here?"

I swallowed, having expected this question. "That's classified information. Amelia is... a... test subject. Only, err, children can accept the treatment. I can't go into further detail."

Amelia stared ahead blankly, resisting the urge to cock an eyebrow at my blatant lie. Ben eyeballed me carefully for a few moments. "That's the dumbest thing I've ever heard. Why would the military put children in harm's way?"

He paused for a moment as he sighed and glanced back out the window. "Judicator... I'm going to believe you. Unlike some of the other higher-ups, I still trust you. I was able to live a long life, tearing across the battlefield thanks to your hypersuits. Because of these suits, an otherwise ordinary man who might have died, all those years ago, was transformed into an unstoppable juggernaut. But you had better watch yourself. Your antics are causing... divisions. I hear a lot of whispers, lately. I'm your ally, but your list of friendlies is dwindling by the day."

I nodded slowly as he spoke. To be honest, it was an alarming statement. I was so insulated from the rest of humanity. It made sense, I suppose. I could see how many might blame me for the attacks on Earth. I still wonder if my Mothership didn't advance the Volgrim threat on Earth decades earlier, as they saw us as a threat. They might have otherwise judged us as primitives, and passed us by for another hundred years or so.

"Thank you for telling me that, Ben. And thank you for trusting me. I'm just trying to protect humanity, the best that I can. As well as my friends." I tilted my head down at Amelia and she looked away from my gaze.

Ben shrugged. "Whatever floats your boat. I'll be back shortly, don't get yourself killed."

Lifting the boy up in his arms, he quickly ran out the door, using his suit's mobility to quickly race away at normally inhuman speeds.

Left behind by ourselves, Amelia shuffled her feet awkwardly as she slowly stared at the ground. "So, what now?"

I set my jaw grimly as an explosion was heard in the distance. "You're going to throw me."

She looked up at me quickly. "What?"

"Like a lance."

"Huh?"

* * *

"Oh. That's what you meant."

We stood on a rooftop looking down at a raging battle in progress. Three hypersuit commandos had their hands full battling just one Dragoon. While they fought, a platoon of regular human and Volgrim infantry were engaged in a vicious battle, blasting one another with hypersonic shotguns and plasma rifles. Many shots missed, but plenty didn't. For every Volgrim downed, two more came to take their place. They were like a swarm of locusts, pouring in from an unseen void in the distance.

There was probably a portal in a nearby building or off in the trees in the distance. I couldn't perceive one, but it had to be there. Even if I closed and sealed it off, how many more were there on Earth? The situation was rather dire.

"So... how hard do you want me to throw you?"

Amelia eyeballed my entire body as she grasped just what she had to do. Considering I towered over her, at nearly eight feet tall, compared with her four foot frame, the idea would ordinarily be absolutely ridiculous. Of course, I had originally planned to use Ben for this

attack, but Amelia would work just fine. This wasn't a normal situation, as she was easily as strong as my hypersuit when it came to pure physical power. There were few that would honestly rival her, Samantha and myself being the only ones that popped into my head immediately.

"Use everything you've got. I'll course correct on the way using my boosters. I'll only have a split second, of course, but that's all my suit needs for something like this."

Amelia blinked slowly as she cricked her neck. "All right. Get ready! I'm going to enjoy this!"

As she suddenly perked up, I had a stupid thought come into my mind. *You're making a small mistake.*

Oh well. We have to take these robots out. I stiffened my body as she easily grabbed me by my stomach and took aim. "Just to warn you, I don't know how good my aim is."

I said nothing in reply. My heart was pounding really fast. Turning off my speakers, I spoke to my AI. "Centurion, make sure we course correct to smash right through the center of that thing. Activate Phase Mode immediately after being thrown, deactivate the instant we arrive inside."

"AFFIRMATIVE, PILOT JASON HIRO. CALCULATIONS IN PROGRESS. CALCULATIONS COMPLETED. YOU MAY LAUNCH WHEN READY."

I swallowed as I activated my speakers again. "Do it!"

The instant the words left my mouth, Amelia gently tossed me forwards, with the force of ten thousand tsunamis crashing into a skyscraper at once. My mind had no time at all to perceive the movement my body had just made. I went from her hand into the ground behind the Dragoon in the blink of an eye, my body smashing into the ground with such force that a massive shockwave erupted outwards and my vision went pure white for a few moments as my mind reeled from the impact.

My mind swam for what felt like an eternity, but was probably closer to a few seconds. As I came to, I noticed that it was all dark around me. Blinking quickly, I struggled to move, realizing that I was actually buried underground.

Struggling mightily, I used my suit's sensors to figure out which way was 'up' and which way was 'down' as I burst out of the ground, glancing back to see an insane sight; the Dragoon had practically evaporated. My HUD showed that my suit had taken nearly ten percent systems damage all over and my inertia dampeners had barely compensated enough to prevent my body from being totally shattered and rebuilt as a pile of Jello.

But the Dragoon... a few portions of legs were scattered here and there, and the fighting had ceased as Volgrim and human alike shifted their eyes around warily, trying to figure out what the hell had destroyed the Dragoon in the blink of an eye. The humans were the first to return to their senses, guessing that it had to be a friendly that took out the mechanical monstrosity. Whooping for joy, they began to surge forwards as they started lighting up the Volgrim with hundreds of hypersonic shotgun bursts, some even using explosive shells with no regard for the environment around them. Feeling the tables turn, the Volgrim began to beat a hasty retreat, laying down cover fire as they quickly hustled their way backwards into the foliage in the distance, well past the 6 foot tall wall that indicated the perimeter of the city.

As for me, I flopped down onto my behind in stunned silence, as I took in the sight of the fragments of the Dragoon that was left over. I was also feeling a bit dizzy due to the impact and a decent amount of damage my body had taken, but that was for the most part the lesser of the two reasons.

Amelia came bouncing over to me, giggling all the way. I was glad she was enjoying herself, but I didn't like that she was taking a perverse delight in my suffering.

"You flew so fast! I didn't even know I had that kind of throwing ability in me! I should be pitching for the Yankees or something!"

I sighed as she laughed and hopped around. At least one of us was having fun.

Still. This was just one battle among many. There was much to do as of yet.

* * *

Vasily Sokolov, commonly known as 'Stonewall', listened carefully to the man on the phone. The man sounded American, judging by his accent. Considering the parasitic aliens had wiped the Americas off the map with a cowardly act of mass destruction, Stonewall was surprised someone was making a holo-call from that area. The trace had turned up positive for a match in what was previously known as North Dakota.

"So you are saying the aliens have access to magic, da?"

The holographic image of a man concealed in shadow nodded slightly. "Yeah. Magic is real, and that human that you call 'Judicator', he has access to it. We suspect that he traveled back in time using it. We know he is the first person who contacted the aliens, and he conveniently had advanced technology that allowed us to fight them on mostly equal terms. We also know that he has been in contact with other parties, parties who don't care so much about the good of humanity."

Stonewall nodded, as he reached over for one of his favorite vintage Cuban cigars. Lighting it with a torch he always kept burning just behind his chair, he took a few long drags. He simmered quietly as he fought to contain his rage.

That spineless weak bitch, Beatrix, she was allying with 'Judicator', or rather, 'Jason Hiro'. But he was allying with foreign powers from another planet, the damned aliens. Stonewall hated the aliens. But he had always hated Beatrix too. She had humiliated him too many times, first by stealing credit for the Final Defense of Earth, when in fact it was this man on the line who had saved the lives of humanity's citizens, and then later when she was appointed to lead the entire military might of the United Earth Forces.

She didn't deserve the privilege. She was a traitor.

Stonewall let out a long breath of smoke as he let those thoughts simmer in his mind. Finally, he spoke again. "The aliens have to go, Silva. You would agree, da?"

Silver nodded. "Yes. I have completed the work that the Fuhrer never finished, well over a century ago. This is it. Type 3 Energy is ours to use." Silver held up a small vial as he shook it around for Stonewall to see. A glowing white liquid sloshed around, its color seeming to indicate a sort of holy purity.

"If the serum is so good, why you not use it before? Why you even bother to ask permission?" Stonewall examined it carefully, the little he could see of it in the holographic image. It seemed like too good of a deal to him.

"It's not perfect. It's merely as good as it gets. The serum has side effects, and the side effects increase dramatically depending on certain traits the participant might possess."

"Side effects?" Stonewall leaned back in his chair. As expected, it was a faulty product. It was flawed and likely wouldn't work. Too bad.

"Yes. The problem is, it relies on personality traits and many other factors to determine what abilities a person gets. It can cause many issues, such as mental psychosis and other... defects. After all, the Fuhrer himself, when he was desperate, he..." Silver paused as he remembered the diary entry that Eva Braun had written on that final night. Horrifying. "...Well, that's not important. What is important is that we know who it will work on and who it won't. If you supply us some men, we'll screen them. We *will* have a counter to the one who calls himself our savior. All I'm asking for is your cooperation."

Stonewall nodded slowly as a small grin spread over his face. "And what if some hotshot goes and makes big mess? You are ready to clean up, da?"

Silver nodded quickly. "Oh yes, indeed we are. The anti-energy weapons are always ready to be turned on those who would betray us."

Stonewall turned and took another puff of his cigar, glancing down at the picture of his late wife and children on the table in front of him. If he couldn't protect them, then at least he could make sure humanity was safe from tyrants in the sky.

"I will send you men and women. You pick ones you like. I hope to do more business with you in future, Silva."

Reaching down, he clicked off the holo-projector as he leaned back in his red velvet chair. Sighing, he glanced over at the casualty reports. Disgusting. This many had died already? Perhaps when they were ready for a real leader, they would push the stupid woman out of the way and let a man take over.

Because that's what humanity really needed. They needed to fight back relentlessly and crush the invaders, make them regret ever coming to Earth.

Stonewall's smile faded as he thought of the good old days. If only times were simple like they were back then.

Part 292a:

Forget the 24th century, the world might be ending hundreds of years ahead of schedule.

Amelia and I had worked together to destroy a few dozen of the Dragoons, but I was beginning to feel exhaustion set in. Even using wordsmithing to refresh my mind and body occasionally wasn't doing what it needed for me.

For three straight days, well past Christmas day, we've fought. No breaks, just unending war. Humans are dwindling in numbers as they're being forced to quickly suit up fresh faces for war. An emergency draft is underway as Beatrix hauls in thousands of people who've never seen combat a day in their lives.

I've already lost some clones. A couple dozen, a small impact considering they number a few thousand now, but nevertheless... I've lost more clones over the last three days than I have the entire century previous. That is actually more frightening than it might sound, given I hadn't lost a single clone until yesterday. My clones are getting sloppy, but also creative.

Having adopted my 'Lancer' strategy, my clones are also taking out Dragoons when encountered, always traveling in twos, using 'swap' and 'clone' to create new suits when needed. The damage to these suits is magical, not physical, meaning the only way to repair a broken suit is to reinforce it dozens of times again and again. Keeping in mind the suits are far more durable and resilient than diamond, adamantium, and any other known alloy, a simple 'repair' spell won't do the trick.

"Centurion, what is Earth's estimated surviving population as of this moment?"

I take a few moments from the chaos to catch a breather as I jump into a nearby tree, quickly examining the chaos with my own eyes.

"PILOT JASON HIRO. THE CURRENT KNOWN REMAINING POPULATION OF EARTH, COUNTING ONLY HUMANS, IS ONE BILLION, TWO HUNDRED MILLION, THREE HUNDRED AND TWENTY THOU-"

I cut him off quickly as he fired off the numbers. "I get the picture. How many are estimated missing? Round it, please."

"PILOT JASON HIRO, ROUGHLY FOUR HUNDRED MILLION ARE ESTIMATED MISSING, WHILE FIVE BILLION CANNOT BE ACCOUNTED FOR DUE TO LACK OF REPORTS FROM THE NORTH AND SOUTH AMERICAN CONTINENTS."

I swallowed hard as he gave me the numbers. "What number of remaining survivors are of military age and capable of fighting?"

There was a short pause as Centurion crunched the numbers. "A RAPID ESTIMATION GIVES BACK FOUR HUNDRED MILLION TO SEVEN HUNDRED MILLION HUMANS OF MILITARY AGE."

I lowered my head, as the numbers set in. It was unthinkable. Earth had lost countless humans, and the Volgrim, while also suffering substantial losses, had realized a war of attrition was their best chance of eliminating us.

What had changed? Desperation must be setting in. If what Dosena had told me was true, their home world would soon be destroyed due to the collapse of their star. If that were the case and somehow their timetable had accelerated, this might be a sort of desperate last resort for them.

What bothered me though, above many other things, was that the leader of the Volgrim was such a powerful magic user. Creating a gas that could devour all life, transporting himself to another dimension... surely terraforming a planet should be within his means magically, if not technologically. And for such an advanced race as the Volgrim, why had they not simply terraformed a new planet?

I shook my head to clear away the thoughts. This wasn't the time.

Ben staggered back from the front lines, his body bent forwards as he also fought to catch his breath. "I... hah... I hope you're done taking a nap, Judicator!"

He flopped down at the base of the tree I was sitting at as he breathed heavily. I jumped to the ground, landing beside him with a solid 'thud'.

"Ben. How's it looking? How long can we hold the line?"

He shook his head. "Not long. We've got maybe a day before we're relying entirely on fresh recruits and a handful of generals. I think we're being sabotaged internally too. Hovercraft keep breaking down, plasma rifles keep jamming, and too many ion grenades have misfired for it to all be a coincidence."

A grimace slips over my face, not that Ben can see it. Sabotage. We can't afford to lose more men and women, yet lose them we will, if this keeps up. Even another ten thousand more hypersuit commandos who have trained heavily their whole lives wouldn't be an elite enough force to defeat this foe. It's like trying to kill a swarm of rats with a baseball bat. Our power is far greater than theirs thanks to the almost cheating nature of the hypersuits, but their numbers overwhelm us entirely.

"Rome is gone. Jerusalem, even Paris is on the brink of destruction. We haven't heard from Japan all day. China is either maintaining radio silence or they're gone, or at the least they've had their communications badly disrupted."

Ben lowers his head as he pops open to wipe tears from his eyes. "Fuck. For it to come to this... I can't even comprehend how many of my friends have died today, Judicator. Tell me... tell me... do you have an ace up your sleeve? Do you have anything that can help us now?"

I swallow carefully as I flip through my options. *Genocide* is one of them. I've never used that word before, and it has a very high chance of backfiring. What if it doesn't kill just the Volgrim, but all other life too? What if it's too weak and only kills some? What if it's plenty powerful, but the magical strain kills me in the process? I've nearly had all of these things happen to me in the past. My wordsmithing has limits, and those limits have nearly resulted in my death many times before.

Of course, this isn't my only possible ace in the hole. There's also... the angels. By now, given how many humans have died, their ranks must be swelling with dead humans. Thought Energy is likely growing beyond slim. At this rate, if humanity dies, the angels will too. But if I call them in for reinforcements, this could be the catalyst that kills them...

...No. It's as I feared. It's almost as if time is repeating the events that will lead to the future I came from. It all adds up. I don't know the details, but the broader picture matches. Even if I don't ask the angels to join in the fight, they must know by now the dire situation we're in. They're probably going to join in to aid their own self preservation.

I glanced back over my shoulder at the city of London. Beautiful resplendent, at least ordinarily... it was in ruins now. The inner city was, for now, untouched, but the outer city limits were a crumbling facade of its previous glory. Amelia wasn't here on the frontlines now, I'd sent her back to rest in the shelter with the other people. She had pinkie promised me that she wouldn't hurt anyone, only Volgrim or demons if they showed up. Having suffered an injury that would easily kill an ordinary human instantly, she was resting with that kid and the other survivors.

If I don't protect this city... if I don't protect humanity, it's all over. Maybe Umi was right. Maybe humans are parasites that will destroy themselves and all other life. But I have to take a chance. I have to trust my gut and do what I can to save my species. I have friends now, and I can't just let them die.

"Ben. I'm leaving the battlefield. Do what you can while I'm gone."

Ben jerked his head to the side and gawked at me. "What?! You can't be- at a time like this?!"

I nodded quickly. "I'm going to get reinforcements. It's time I used my trump card."

His jaw hanging slack, he stared at me for several moments before regaining his senses. "Reinforcements? Who the hell would be able to give us aid at a time like this? There's nobody who doesn't already have their hands tied left. There's just... nobody."

"Ben." I turned and flicked my visor open, exposing my face to him. Ben jerked away from me, not expecting a sudden face reveal. "I consider you one of my closest friends. My real name is Jason Hiro. I was born in the year 1998. And... I've been keeping something from you, and the rest of humanity. Something important. I'd tell you what that is, but you'll see soon enough. It's time to put my faith in humanity, and let them place their full trust in me."

Ben stared carefully at my face, imprinting it to his memory as best as he could. "Jason... Hiro... so you're the one we've called Judicator, huh?" He swallowed carefully as he flicked his eyes from me to a massive explosion in the distance, and back again. "Jason... I've always put my trust in you. I'll continue to trust you until the day I die. Bring us your reinforcements. I just hope to god they're at least as useful as your... clones are."

I felt a smile creep onto my face as he mentioned 'god'. "Oh yes. And then some. I'll be back soon, don't you worry."

Closing my visor up, I used a word I hadn't spoken in quite a long time. " **Teleport.** "

* * *

Ricky dabbed the cotton ball gently on Amelia's arm, but she still winced. The nurses were all busy helping the older folks, ones who hadn't had an injection of retention drugs in a while. Their nanobots weren't performing adequately enough, given their advanced age. Ricky didn't know a single thing about first aid, but he did what he could.

Amelia breathed shallowly as her chest rose and fell barely a centimeter at a time. Of course, the gaping hole in her chest had been healed by Jason before he put her here, but the spiritual energy loss had been tremendous. She was laying on her back, both arms flopping lifelessly beside her inert body. She could hardly move at all, her fingers barely twitching whenever Ricky dabbed at the few remaining open wounds with his cotton balls.

Ricky wiped sweat from his head. Despite being the middle of winter and freezing cold outside, it was close to a hundred degrees in this Hyperbowl dome. The failsafes had fizzled out thanks to damage to the grid, and the upper space heaters were now working nonstop, unable to monitor the temperature outside.

Ricky took another dip of the washcloth in the basin and placed it on Amelia's head. Glancing down at his holo-watch, he carefully read the first aid instructions as they were given to him, not missing even a single word.

Amelia coughed slightly as her eyes slowly blinked open. "Ricky... oh, you're here... too..."

Ricky nearly jumped out of his skin. "You're awake! I was so worried!"

Amelia didn't smile or express any emotion as her eyes closed again. "Where am I...?"

"We're in the Hyperbowl dome. It's one of the emergency refugee shelters for when the big bad aliens attack!"

"Oh... where's Jason, then?"

Ricky cocked an eyebrow. Jason? The name didn't ring a bell at all. "I don't know who that is."

"He's... the guy in the suit... the white suit..."

Ricky suddenly nodded enthusiastically. "Oh yeah! You must mean Judicator, not Jason! His suit has the Eagle on it, right? He's that time traveler guy! He's so cool!"

Amelia swallowed as saliva was building up in her throat. "Mmm. Yeah, him. So... where is he?"

Ricky shrugged, then realized her eyes were closed and she couldn't see him. "Dunno. He dropped you off here, called for me, and left. He's prolly still fighting the aliens."

Amelia exhaled slowly as she gritted her teeth together. A sharp wave of pain had erupted in her chest from speaking. She hadn't experienced pain like this in centuries. After a few moments, she recovered her senses and opened her eyes again slowly. "That's... just like him. Ah, now I remember. I was awake. I got hit by a big spider-thing. It shot me with its gun. Levvy saved me. Jason brought me here... I remember now."

Ricky nodded and smiled as the two of them stared at each other for a few moments. He started to say something but suddenly the dome was filled with an incredibly bright light, as something incredibly shiny and radiant lit up the entire sky outside. The outside of the dome was covered on top by extremely dense nano-glass, which kept the weather out, but allowed the light in.

Ricky winced as the unbelievably brilliant light blasted in, slowly moving across the horizon. After a few moments, his eyes had adjusted and he looked up into the sky, seeing thousands of tiny figures flying across the sky, let by one figure that was easily a hundred times their size. Even from here, Ricky could clearly make out the wings, the white clothing, the armor... it was almost as if...

Amelia stared up at the sky, her mind almost being unable to comprehend what she was seeing. "Angels... It can't be..."

* * *

Beatrix stared blankly at the videos arriving on her feed. These images were utterly preposterous. Angels? It couldn't be.

Several officers who had been running about frantically paused to gawk at the main viewscreen affixed to the wall. There was one titanic angel, towering over all others, and tens of thousands of other ones following immediately behind him.

Where they had come from was anyone's guess. Some said that if they looked directly up at the sun in the sky, the angels appeared to come out of the brightness itself.

But despite being angels, were they friend or foe?

No. Wait. Beatrix suddenly cast her eyes down to her feet as several other distinct thoughts presented themselves. If these were actually angels, then... suddenly the odd 'demonic variant' Volgrim made all too much sense. They weren't variants. The man she had spoken with, just a few days previously, he had mentioned magical energy. He had said something unsettling about Judicator's origins, but now... she had to believe what he was saying, at least a little bit.

"Those can't seriously be angels, can they?" A young female field officer stared hopefully at the screen before her.

Beatrix opened her mouth to speak, but was verbally tossed aside as a different voice spoke up from the doorway of the room. "Indeed they are, dear friends. Angels, demons, aliens, humans, da. The four true players in this war."

Beatrix glanced to her side to see a familiar man standing in the doorway, wearing a pinstriped military suit with a dozen medals attached to the front pocket, just above his heart. Smoking a vintage Cuban cigar, he strode forwards with purpose to the War Table.

Beatrix stifled a glare at him. He was a veteran player in the war, and an important man, especially when it came to his iron-fisted discipline on board the starship legion he commanded. While he was well known for disliking Beatrix, humanity came before petty civil disputes. "Stonewall. Glad to see you here. You know about these angels?"

"Da. I have many contacts who have enlightened me on their nature too, da. Temporary allies, they are. Expendable pawns to protect our own men and women. If they are here, then we have entered the final stage of this Christmas Genocide."

Beatrix blanched. "The final stage? Then they're going to turn on us?"

Stonewall chuckled. "Is that thick head of yours empty? I mean it is the chance for us to completely destroy the alien scum, for good. We will begin the pushback at once, da."

Turning his head, he spoke to an ensign on the bridge. "You there, you control the targeting systems for long ranged missiles, da?"

The young man nodded nervously. "Yes, Fleet Commander Stonewall, sir."

"Excellent. Target these coordinates with a high-yield ion barrage, followed by a bunker-buster stormhead missile." Stonewall handed a slip of paper to the young man.

The young man glanced uneasily from the paper to Beatrix. "Supreme Commander...?"

She flicked her eyes towards Stonewall. "You wanna tell me what's going on?"

"I have intel. I use the intel. Do I need your permission, *Supreme Commander*?" Stonewall inserted the slightest mocking tone into his voice, causing Beatrix to clench a fist inside her pocket.

"No. Do what you will, we're glad to have you helping us."

"Of course you are." Stonewall blinked slowly as his gaze traveled back to the young ensign. The man was already quickly typing the numbers in, his eyes twitching as he saw where they were aiming. "Sir... these coordinates are... right outside the city."

"I am aware, green. Fire."

The young man shot a glance over at Beatrix for the slightest of moments before pressing the 'fire' command.

"Track the shots. I want to see the impact zone." Beatrix spoke to the young man, as Stonewall smiled ever so slightly. The holoscreen instantly changed to a satellite signal as it showed the area they were targeting. Volgrim appeared to be flowing out of an unseen spot on screen, firing immediately on the humans a short distance away as they took up flanking positions.

Beatrix blanched. "We have soldiers there! They're going to die!"

The smile disappeared from Stonewall's face. "Some will die, da. A sacrifice for the greater good. We will seal off their portal to our world, or we will die. The angels will help us clean up your mess afterwards."

Beatrix glanced uneasily at Stonewall. "What are you insinuating, *Mister Sokolov*? Are you implying this is somehow my fault?"

A snarl passed by Stonewall's lips momentarily at her use of his last name before he quickly righted himself. "Of course not, my dear Beatrix. These aliens were an unexpected attack. However, the way you have dealt with their invasion is... inadequate."

Beatrix felt fury building as she struggled to right herself. "So you're saying you might have done a better job?"

"Da. I already am. You never even thought to seal off their method of arrival. Take a look."

Just as she turned back, a hail of ion-cannon fire smashed into the area, followed by a massive explosion as the bunker buster detonated directly on the spot where the Volgrim appeared to be entering through.

"But... that couldn't possibly seal the portal. That might kill many Volgrim, but they can still come here."

Stonewall raised and wagged a chiding finger. "Ah, my dear Beatrix. You are wrong. The explosion passed through their portal, crippling the inner facility where they make these gates to enter our world. You know so little, I fear."

Beatrix gawked as she stared at the screen. Indeed, no more Volgrim were appearing as the rest scattered in confusion. Without a steady stream of reinforcements, they would eventually be dispatched.

"Inner facility... how do you know anything about how they're making these portals?"

Stonewall shrugged. "Is surprising you do not know, to be honest." He took a long slow drag off his cigar. "Did you think these portals simply appeared from nowhere? They had to be made from somewhere, a central facility is obvious answer, da?"

As he spoke the rhetorical question, a smile cracked on the side of his mouth. "Of course, I was told of this by one of many moles I have inside the Volgrim ranks. You cannot defeat they who you do not understand."

Turning around slowly and deliberately, Stonewall walked away from the War Table. "I will be back after you have cleaned up mess. We will be discussing your upcoming re-election campaign in great detail, I assure you. The people will know who saved humanity in the end."

Beatrix felt her face lighting up red as he confidently strode out of the room, ignoring any response she might have. As the door closed she quickly barked at a nearby ensign. "Status update!"

The young girl flinched at her tone and quickly scanned the screen in front of her. "T-the Volgrim numbers have stopped rising, their supply lines around the world seem to have been cut off. We don't have any contact with a few member countries... but... it seems that Fleet Commander Stonewall was..." The girl glanced over at Beatrix before lowering her gaze. "...right."

Beatrix slowly panned the room with her eyes. Nearly everyone had their eyes fixed on her. A few were shaking their heads ever so slightly.

Swallowing carefully and deliberately, she brought her temper down to normal levels. "I see. Thank you for the... status update. Let's get back to fighting, we don't need any more dead soldiers on our hands, ladies and gentlemen."

As she raised her gaze to the holoscreen, she eyeballed the angels that had just arrived on the battlefield. *What the hell was going on?*

Part 293a:

It was the 29th of December, in the year 2100, when humanity finally learned of the Angels. America, always a bastion of devoutly religious believers, had been wiped off the map before their suspicions had been confirmed. Almost a hundred years earlier, a poll had been taken of the world in which citizens of North America had a 46% suspicion or direct belief that angels were real.

If they had not been annihilated mere days before, they might have been overjoyed at this incredible sight. Instead, the angels became a grim reminder of the world's loss of two major continents.

The wrath of the gods, long unseen by the citizens of Earth, was swift and merciless. They came first in hundreds, then thousands, then millions. A swift unending torrent of death and destruction. Streaming from an unseen portal high in the sky, they rained holy retribution on the aliens that had come to kill their pious believers. Even the atheists, large in number though they might be, were instantly converted into believers on that great day. Would their faith prove unshakable like a mountain? Only time would be the judge of that.

As for me, I had long come to accept the existence of gods and angels. The only thing I had not come to accept, however, was the belief that they were pious and righteous. They were an ally of humanity, to an extent, but only in that I viewed them as parasites that depended on humans to sustain their existence.

Many angels, especially the pseudo-angels who had been reborn after their death, were genuinely good and honest beings, but plenty were not. Their convictions and reasons mattered little though, in the grand scheme of things. It was their *power* that made them valuable allies. A single angel was far stronger, faster, and wielded vastly more spiritual energy than a regular human. While not comparing to the power of a Hypersuit Commando, even the weakest pseudo-angel could be said to be a god when compared to the average human.

I watched wordlessly as a single angel slammed into the ground beside a ten-strong company of Volgrim, his hand swinging down a blade made of pure spiritual energy, slicing through a Volgrim in the blink of an eye. Before the others had taken a moment to react, he cut down two more. As they leveled their weapons at him, another angel landed beside him, the impact shaking the very ground they stood on.

In seconds, all ten Volgrim were dispatched with ease. As the humans watched with awe on their faces, the Hypersuit Commandos quickly began using their limited numbers and

incredible firepower to focus down the Dragoons, leaving the small-fry Volgrim to the angels. Within the hour, most Volgrim on Earth were killed, though some were captured to be later interrogated.

I switched my feed to world news stations as various Britannian TV personalities started babbling their ideas about what was going on, who these angels were, and what it all meant in the grand scheme of things. Shaking my head slowly, I deactivated the feed.

To me, this was an empty victory. Many have called me foolish, but anyone who understood how the dynamics of the three Earth clans worked would understand this was the worst possible outcome. The angels possessed unimaginable power, which, when combined, easily dwarfed even my own abilities. But that power came at a heavy price, both for themselves and humanity. They had withdrawn themselves from the eyes of the general public for a reason. They had formed alliances with the true elites among humans to suppress and hide all information of their existence for a reason. Everything they did was for a reason.

The fact that they were here now... it meant they had admitted defeat. If humans died, the angels would soon follow. This admittance of their existence meant they had been driven into a corner.

I swallowed as I spoke to my onboard AI. "Centurion. What is the probability of victory for the Britannian forces today?"

His voice responded, and while it sounded just as hollow as usual, he somehow seemed to be pleased with the results. "PILOT JASON HIRO, THE CHANCE OF VICTORY HAS INCREASED TO 99.99%, BASED ON THE REMAINING COMBINED COMBAT ABILITIES OF THE HUMANS AND ANGELS. THE ONLY POSSIBLE CHANCE OF DEFEAT WOULD BE AN UNKNOWN ABERRATION, SUCH AS A TOTAL AND COMPLETE SHUTDOWN OF ALL BIOLOGICAL ACTIVITY AT ONCE."

"Great... that's great. Thank you, Centurion."

I slumped down to sit on a nearby rock as I lowered my head to the ground. Trees burned in the distance as Volgrim desperately fired their plasma rifles at vegetation, trying to cause any damage they possibly could in their final moments. The angels extinguished the fires with the barest use of their magical powers.

As I sat, a familiar form walked up from behind me. Glancing up, I nodded at him. "Raphael."

The old archangel ambled up to me, leaning heavily on his old gnarled cane. Too heavily, if you asked me. He hardly seemed to need it, using it mostly for show. "You seem disheartened, young mortal. Something on your mind?"

"We've lost, haven't we?"

He stared ahead for a moment after hearing my response. Sighing slowly, he shuffled his feet slightly. "Now, whatever might you mean by that?"

I explained my thoughts to him as he nodded and listened intently. "Ah, so you believe the angels are doomed, now that we've shown ourselves to the humans? A wise observation. Likely correct, if I don't say so myself."

I cocked my head as I heard muffled screams in the distance. They were bloodcurdling, likely the sound of a Volgrim facing certain death. The sounds ended abruptly, just as his life probably did. "So you agree."

Raphael shrugged lightly, a motion I wouldn't have expected a wise archangel to use. "Perhaps, perhaps not. You seem to be convinced that the future is repeating itself."

I rose to my feet, now towering above the archangel, who was of small stature compared to my titanic body. "Well? Isn't it?"

"I do not know. I only know of the prediction that you gave. Earth will eventually be partially destroyed, humans will be enslaved, and the angels will all be killed off. The demons will reign supreme, and all hope will be lost. Certainly not an ideal future, if I might say so myself."

I grumbled silently to myself regarding his dispassionate explanation of the future I came from. "You don't seem to care all that much, if you ask me."

"Perhaps I am not so convinced that the future is set in stone." Raphael glanced over to me, cocking his eye questioningly. "Why do you assume that it is? Perhaps it is your tacit agreement that the future will stay the same, that the rivers of time will not change their course. Perhaps it is your actions, or your lack thereof, that cause the future to occur."

I found myself raising an eyebrow questioningly at his words. "That could certainly be the case. What are you trying to imply?"

Again he shrugged as he averted his gaze from mine. "I'm just an ancient old man. I only know what I know of the past, and nothing about the future. Many times have some predicted the end of the angels, or the demons, or the humans. All of those times, they have been wrong. Why do you suppose that is?"

"I'm not sure. Luck? It wasn't their time?"

Raphael rolled his eyes mockingly. "I suppose, if you're a simpleton, that might be the case. However, I suspect a more complicated reason is why. Perhaps there is another who guides the universe towards a path of His choosing."

I blinked slowly. *Oh*. That's what he means. "You think the Creator is guiding the universe then?"

Raphael smiled a toothy grin at me. "Perhaps. Perhaps not. Do you think he *isn't*?"

I groaned inwardly as the old man played word games with me. This was not what I felt like talking about. "I don't know, Raphael. I thought the angels were made in the Creator's image. Don't you know who he actually is, in that case?"

Raphael's grin disappeared. "Nay. I may have known his identity, or hers, or 'theirs', as it were, but that was eons upon eons ago. That was another life. Now I know nothing of His persona, only that which He left behind for us to witness."

Right... so the old man thinks the creator has a grand plan for the universe... where have I heard that before? "Alright, so if he has a plan, then does that plan involve the angels being killed?"

Raphael nodded. "Indeed, it may. Humans created a genre of games they call 'simulation', where fake humans go about with their fake lives. The player even has the choice of eradicating their world for fun and sport. Would a Creator above ourselves not be in a similar position to us compared to that game?"

I cocked an eyebrow. "I'm surprised you know anything about video games. As for the question, I suppose that might be the case, but it makes our existences rather hollow and meaningless."

"Existence is suffering." Raphael nodded matter-of-factly, as if that put an end to the entire discussion. Jeez, I didn't know an archangel could be so nihilistic.

"You seem to have a lot to say today. Why is that?" I decided to try the direct approach, given its excellent track record over my lifetime.

Raphael turned away from me as he started to shuffle away. "Oh, I don't know. An old man sometimes just wants to speak his mind, you know. Especially to a depressed looking whippersnapper moping around like the world just ended, and after winning a major battle at that!"

As he walked away, I glanced around myself at the bodies as far as I could see, the plumes of smoke billowing into the air, and the crumbled buildings in the distance. "If this is a win, I don't want to see a loss, old friend."

* * *

Amelia sipped at the water that Ricky had given her. It tasted awful, just as any normally edible or drinkable substance would taste to her, but she powered through it anyway. She didn't

want to make the stupid boy cry.

Grumbling as every sip tasted like dog urine, she finally finished the cup and coughed lightly, tossing the styrofoam container to the side as she lay back down on her back. It was miserably hot in the Hyperdome, and she was feeling greatly uncomfortable due to being around tens of thousands of other people in the same enclosed space. All around herself, people were chattering and blabbing endlessly, their voices like a loud roar coming from all directions at once.

Leviathan appeared in her mind as she groaned audibly again. "Princess, are you feeling... well?"

Ricky was nowhere in sight at the moment, so she didn't feel uncomfortable speaking out loud around all the strangers milling about. "No, Levvy... I feel terrible. This place reeks of humans. It's hotter than Hell, too."

Leviathan chuckled. "I'll take your word for it, even though we've never been there. We should pay my previous pupil a visit some time." Leviathan paused for a moment as he realized what he had said. "Never mind, that is not what I wish."

Amelia closed her eyes as she visualized Leviathan's physical appearance from the last time she had seen him, millennia ago. "Levvy... I won't forget my promise to you. I'll make him pay for keeping you locked up."

Leviathan let out a long sigh at her statement. "Princess... it is no longer necessary. We are bonded for life. Perhaps, by his treatment of me, it was part of a larger picture, so that we might meet. Perhaps what he did, even if unintentional, was the best thing that ever happened to you and I. I regret nothing in my life, neither should you."

Amelia cracked an eye open. "Oh? What about Jason? You're saying I shouldn't regret calling him my friend?"

Leviathan snickered softly. "Heh, always with the sharp wit. I stand by what I said before. Jason is dangerous, he simply doesn't know that himself. He is like a spark dancing next to dry hay. Sooner or later, he will cause a great fire that will burn the barn to the ground."

Leviathan paused as his voice suddenly had a tinge of uncertainty to it. "...Still, I do not wish a life of endless war and killing on you. I do not like that you must devour life to sustain your own. I am far less sure of things than I was when I was free."

"When you were... free?" Amelia opened both eyes as a feeling of sadness washed over her. "Do you feel trapped inside of me? Do you want to be free again?"

Leviathan didn't respond for a few moments, before a slow response finally came. "...Yes. But I cannot. You would perish, should that happen. And... if you were to perish, I should not be able to go on myself."

Amelia suddenly felt something inside of her eye. Reaching up, she wiped it off only to discover that she was again crying. This was the second time in a mere week that she had done so, in a long life of never once displaying negative emotions.

Leviathan immediately picked up on it. "Princess, are you-...?"

She shook her head quickly as she leaned up to a sitting position and quickly dried her eyes. "Ah, no, it's just so hot in here, I must have felt faint for a moment, and I-"

Leviathan chortled loudly at her sudden flustered words. "Ah Princess, it means much to an old dragon that you would shed tears over the thought of my death. But worry not, we will always have one another. I would never allow someone to cause harm to you....Never."

Amelia nodded as she felt herself smiling. "Thank you... Levvy. We'll always be there for each other. Nobody can break our bond. If anyone were to try, we would just kill them."

From deep within, Leviathan did not respond to her. However, she had the distinct impression that the thought of killing had somehow saddened him. He had been slowly but surely changing over the centuries... he was simply not the same overly haughty dragon that he used to be.

Perhaps it was for the better. Perhaps it was just the way things had to be.

* * *

Unarin kept his emotions neutral as he examined the final report. By the numbers, it was a success, but not a victory. They had succeeded in badly crippling the humans, and had caused the angels to reveal themselves to the general public. Many Volgrim had died, the outrageously high number was something that had nearly caused Unarin's blood to boil over.

Still, the timetable was too tight. Their planet did not have much time left. They needed a new home for their people, and soon. Perhaps diplomacy was the only way? No, the humans were far too angered to acquiesce a single thing to the Volgrim they hated so much.

He had at one point asked Satan what it would take to create a dimensional space big enough to house the Volgrim... but the soul cost was too unbelievable. Such a number would cripple their capabilities for generations. It was better than extinction, but not by much.

Unarin licked his armored tongue across his razor-sharp teeth, hissing sharply as he read the numbers again. Damn. *If only Dosena were still here.*

Glancing across the table at the other Founders, they all appeared to be staring ahead blankly, with nothing better to do. They had all just finished reading the reports, and clearly none were pleased.

Given it was his right and duty to speak first, Unarin broke the silence. "I have come to a decision regarding Dosen's replacement."

Instantly, the other Founders turned their head towards him. Trayza, the third in command, suppressed a smile. Finally, she would have the chance to curry favor with Unarin as his second in command. With her love of war, potentially surpassing Dosen's, her psionic abilities would no longer be mocked, as her commanding abilities on the battlefield would propel them to inevitable victory regardless of her lacking in mental areas.

She started to thank Unarin, but he continued speaking. "Regarding the position of Second Founder, I have chosen Elder Nufaris as the new second Founder. I have not told him of this yet."

Unarin paused as he caught a glimpse of shock flutter around the table as each other Founder expressed the slightest hint of revulsion at his choice.

"Elder Nufaris?! But he's not even a High Vizier! Nor is he a Battle Commander or a Warrior General! What qualifications could he-?!" Trayza shot off her mouth, then suddenly slapped it shut realizing the disrespect she had just shown. "I... beg your pardon. I did not mean to... express such a show of emotion."

As she tilted her head down, she felt rage and embarrassment flow through her, both at being ignored for the role of Second, and for her outburst.

Unarin graciously accepted her apology. "Trayza... I did not make this choice lightly. I hope you will forgive me for not putting you in your rightful position as Second. However, with regards to the matter of the Humans... I have been debating a new tactic. I know not how it will work, but Elder Nufaris is the only one who has had as much contact with a human as I have, but in a more diplomatic manner. Ignoring his abilities and renown or lack thereof, he was the obvious choice for me to pick, given he has spoken personally with the Hero that leads the humans."

Trayza stared forwards quietly, merely nodding her head in response.

Unarin sent a mental signal to the guards outside, as they sent Elder Nufaris into the Founders Contemplation Room.

Unarin kept his face neutral as he looked at the small Volgrim before him. "Elder Nufaris, for your service to your people, both recently and in the past, you have been elected the Second

Founder of Volgarius. Your new title will be 'The Soothsayer'."

As Nufaris had a flash of joy pass over his face, Unarin chuckled quietly to himself. *The perfect pawn, and not a fool like Trayza. He will do decently, until I can find an ideal replacement.*

Part 294a:

"Hello Tom, I'm on the scene now amidst the chaos that has engulfed the outer city limits of London. The south side of the city has been all but annihilated by the Volgrim, but these winged saviors that came from the sky have appeared to pacify all the remaining aliens."

"Excellent work, Jane. We'll be back to speak with you after a commercial break. And coming up later, we're inviting several world-renowned scientists to our expert panel to give opinions on the identities of these winged visitors. Are they angels? Stay tuned to learn more on this developing story!"

As the feed switched to commercial break, I sighed quietly. As planned, the angels had quickly mopped up, then returned to each of the hidden portals I'd kept a half-mile above the ground. It was pretty obvious to just about anyone that these were angels, but for the sake of the ever worsening 24 hour news rush that had only gotten worse over the last century, the news channels had to drag everything out and focus on each significant act in order to meet their time tables.

Walking through the shelter, I turned my attention away from the news feed in my helmet to the little girl laying on the ground some feet away. Amelia wasn't doing so hot, a testament to how powerful those anti-magic weapons were. If they could deal this kind of damage to even her... then...

I glanced down at my armored palm. If I could integrate one of those anti-magic weapons into my suit somehow, then I should be able to easily crush Satan. He was a formidable foe, and I suspected even stronger than Amelia, but those anti-magic weapons were absolutely debilitating versus even my hypersuit.

Still... the more I thought about it, the more something was beginning to bother me. We seemed to be heading towards the exact same future that I remembered before I went back in time. What if Raphael's cryptic suggestions were serious? Perhaps my actions *and* my inaction might be causing us to head towards that future. But then, in that case, which was the correct path to take? If I kill Amelia now, that future definitely cannot come to pass, but what if that's the absolute wrong thing to do? If I kill her, then she won't kill Satan. I'd have to do that myself, and I'm not sure that I *can*.

Looking at her motionless body now, I'm not sure that she can either. Perhaps just by speaking to her, I've interrupted the chain of events that might cause her to seek him out and fight him. Even looking beyond Amelia for a moment, I could just kill all the humans, then that

future definitely won't come to pass. I could drop a meteor on Volgarius. I could detonate an atomic bomb inside the labyrinth, or more than a couple of them.

But... I don't want to do any of those things. I've been killing, maiming, and murdering for so long... is this who I want to be? How can I call myself a 'Hero', looking at my kill count? Superman is a hero, and he never kills anyone. But then, The Punisher is sometimes considered a hero too, perhaps the type of hero we need in real life is different from the one in a fantasy wonderland...

As thoughts roil in my mind, Amelia stirs and opens her eyes, looking up at my faceless armored visage. "Oh, Jason. You're here now."

I shake the thoughts out of my head as my speakers turn on. "Yeah, are you alright? You seem violently ill."

"I've never felt this bad before..." Amelia's normally high pitched girly voice is muted substantially, as she seems to be barely choking the words out for me to hear. Her voice reminds me of when I was punched in the stomach in high school and I could barely speak for minutes afterwards until I got my second wind.

I disable my speakers for a moment as I wordsmith at her. **"Heal."** Turning my speakers back on, I smile even though she can't see my face, hoping it will come through in my voice. "There. Does that feel any better?"

As I ask the question, my bio-reading functions come up indicating her circulation and breathing has improved greatly. Before she responds, I already know what her answer will be. "Yeah! I'm feeling way better!" Sitting up abruptly, she flexes her arms a bit, winding her arms around in circular patterns. "The pain is almost gone! How did you do that?"

I frown slightly. "What do you mean? Heal you?"

She nods. "Yeah! You seem to be able to do everything, from destroying to creating to healing! I wanna know how you do it all!"

I swallow, realizing this is a crucial moment. "Well, err, it's not that I don't want to tell you..."

Instantly a pouting expression crosses her face. "Aw, come on! We're friends! You can tell me..."

As she sulks, I feel a silent fear creeping up my spine. Damn! This is a catch 22. If I tell her about wordsmithing, she'll be able to know my powers. If I don't, she won't trust me.

Biting my lip, I quickly glance around the Hyperdome. There's nothing to do and the seconds are crawling by. I can't just distract her from the question, and even if I did, she'd ask it again

later on. Stalling for time, I try my own question. "Well, Amelia, if you've been hurt before, how did you end up healing yourself?"

Her pouting face turned into a lopsided grin. "That's easy! My friend does it for me!"

I bob my head slowly, remembering her friend that she calls 'Levvy' but never wants to tell me anything about. A figment of her imagination? Perhaps something more?

"Why haven't you ever asked your friend how to heal yourself?" Glancing around my HUD, I suddenly remember my other clone only a few blocks away helping with the cleanup, shooting him a list of telepathic commands, I begin to formulate a plan.

Amelia sighs. "It's not that easy! He, err, well he heals me from within! It's his power, not... mine..." She glances away uneasily at the topic the conversation has shifted towards. She *really* doesn't like me knowing anything about her friend. I grin at the thought. *Yeah well, that's how I feel having you ask about my powers.*

As she stares uneasily at a wall to my side, she suddenly bobs her head back. "But that's not an answer to my question! What are your abilities? How do you heal people and do all that cool stuff?"

The moment of truth. Rising to my feet, I stare upwards in a manner that I think is cool. "Heh, it's pretty easy, to be honest. I have a lot of magical energy inside of myself, and I simply manifested my heroic abilities in a way that allows me to conjure a lot of different abilities at once! But anyone could do it, with practice!"

Amelia's face shines with disbelief. "Oh. It's that simple, huh? Well, prove it then."

Her sudden insistence on seeing my abilities demonstrated is not just annoying, but worrisome. Still, I don't want to take a chance, so in order to make it as convincing as possible, I take her hand and walk over to a quiet and semi-empty section of the Hyperdome. Checking to make sure nobody's watching, I send the telepathic order to my clone, who uses 'Remove' on me, taking my Hypersuit off. Of course, the fact my clones can simply remove the Hypersuit from my body scares me, making me realize how easily a rogue clone could have disarmed and killed me in the blink of an eye.

Still, that's not important right now. Standing in front of Amelia, without my Hypersuit, I grin awkwardly at her as I close my eyes and pretend to meditate for a few moments. I can practically feel her interested eyes boring a hole in my face as I hold my palm upwards. "The key, Amelia, is to focus on the power inside your body, giving it life inside your mind. If you focus, you can make your energy manifest however you want it too. For example, by healing a wound."

Holding my palm up, a knife suddenly appears in it. Amelia takes a step back, seeing it appear out of nowhere. "Wow! Was that sleight of hand? I didn't even see how that appeared!"

I chuckle, as I send another telepathic signal to my clone. "No, it's my power. I can manifest anything my mind desires. Watch." Taking the knife with my right hand, I cut lightly into my palm. The moment I cut, I see the wound instantly beginning to close itself. *Oops, my inner regeneration is still active... but...*

Amelia gawks. "Wow! You healed yourself in the blink of an eye! You didn't even do any... magic motions... or anything..." She suddenly glances up at me suspiciously. "Come to think of it, I've never seen a hero or a demon or an angel that *didn't* use magic signs with their hands. Are you playing me for a fool?"

I quickly toss my head up. "Hah! You think signs are necessary? You are like a baby when it comes to your magical abilities! I discovered the secret of using magic without the signs!"

She grumbles slightly and averts her eyes, but seems to accept it. "Alright... well, how can I heal myself then? How can I do anything that you do?"

I shrug. "It's all about the mental focus. Magic is about overcoming your limitations and using your mind to envision what you want. If you don't have a solid vision, nothing will materialize."

I stifle a grin. I hope she doesn't notice that I'm bullshitting and making it up as I go along, but she seems to be absorbing my words carefully as I speak. "Hmm... hmm... ah! I see now! It all makes sense!"

I feel my heart pause for a second as she nods vigorously while resting a finger on her lips. "It... it does?"

"Of course! It's so obvious!" Amelia smacked her head in a "d'oh!" manner, as she grabbed the knife from my hand, cutting deeply into her palm, at first it didn't succeed in even breaking the skin, instead bending the knife, but eventually it did make a small cut.

Amelia mumbled quietly to herself. "No, Levvy, let me do it this time..."

Using her other hand, she began to mumble some nonsensical words that I took as generic magic chants. Glancing down at her hand, she frowned. It was still cut open. As she put on a determined face, she tried again, and again, and three more times, until just when I was losing interest, she suddenly shrieked at the top of her lungs. "OH MY GOSH! I did it! Look, Jason, looky!" As she waved her hand in front of my face, I smiled as I reached down and patted her head.

"Nice job! You got the hang of that pretty fast!" As I smiled, I suddenly felt another feeling wash over my body. A thought occurred to me... *She didn't know how to heal herself until just now...*

But... I taught her how to do it...

As she hopped around shouting joyfully, I swallowed an especially thick gulp. Something about this... was...

Feeling my hands start to shake, I sent another mental order to my clone, who wordsmithed my Hypersuit back onto me. Glancing around nervously, I had another thought creep into my mind. *I hope nobody saw me take the suit off and put it back on...*

Still, I was no longer wearing the face of Jason Hiro. Anyone who saw me wouldn't be able to easily identify me. It was fine. Yeah... it was fine.

Sighing quietly now that I was back inside my Hypersuit, I placed my hand on Amelia's shoulder. "Well, are you ready to go home now?"

She nodded enthusiastically. "Yes! I can't wait to try out more magical abilities!"

I nodded as the smile faded from my face, sending a telepathic symbol to Harold to beam us up.

Moments later, we were standing aboard the Mothership's bridge, staring out at the vast starry sky the represented Outer Space.

I can't change what's already been done, I can only live with it now.

* * *

Silver stood inside Stonewall's office, glancing around at all sorts of beautiful weapons that had been taken from ancient parts of the world. Two swords were criss-crossed on the wall atop a Nordic looking wooden shield, the image of a bear carved into its front section. He noted a halberd, a massive warhammer, and even a flail with dozens of spikes all over it.

As he shuffled his feet, he glanced down at the vial in his hands. *The end result of our experiments.* A pure white fluid swirled around inside of it, the serum designed based on previously lost Nazi human experimental trials. Their goals of creating the perfect super-soldier had failed, but they were on the right track.

As he stood and stared at the various decorations, the door opened to his side and Stonewall strode in. His massive hulking body was tempered only by his finely tailored suit and the massive cigar in his mouth. "Mister Silva, my apologies for keeping you waiting." His thick Russian accent didn't hamper his ability to speak English, it only made it obvious that it was not his native tongue.

Taking a few steps forward, his huge stride placed him in front of Silver, as he leaned forwards to pluck a fresh cigar from a golden cigar holder on the table. Glancing back, he spoke again. "Oh, so rude of me. You want to have smoke as well, da?"

Silver shook his head politely. "No thank you, I'm not a smoker."

Stonewall stared at the small man for a moment before shaking his head slightly with a *tsk* passing his lips. "Such unfortunate that you do not enjoy the taste of smoke in your mouth. It might increase your testosterone a bit, make you into a bigger man." Striding around the desk, Stonewall took a seat in his luxurious easy chair, tossing a glance towards the small wooden chair on the other side of the desk. Silver took a seat there, noting that it was much more comfortable than it might otherwise ordinarily appear.

Gripping the vial in his hands tightly, Silver suddenly felt uncomfortable when faced with the mountain of a man in person. He was far more formidable when not viewed as a hologram or on a viewscreen. "Well then, let's get to business, shall we?"

Stonewall took a few puffs before deigning to respond. "I see you have brought goods. You say this energy is of much power, da? Perhaps a demonstration is in order." His tone indicated an order, not a question.

Silver reached into his loosely fitting brown leather jacket, pulling a small obsolete appearing thumb drive out, as he handed it across the table to the Russian man.

Stonewall eyed it for a moment before reaching out and snatching it from Silver's fingers in the blink of an eye. Looking it up and down, he turned quizzically to Silver. "What is this? It looks familiar, but I have not seen something like this in decades."

"I work for a government agency of sorts. We tend to use old hardware for backup. This is a USB drive, with images and videos of the unsuccessful, and the successful tests of the serum. Just put it into your Deconstructor and it will be able to read the data."

Stonewall examined the small thumb drive carefully before reaching into a drawer on his side of the desk and pulling out a small device with a large aperture for placing objects into. Setting the stick inside, he glanced over at Silver, who nodded in response. Wordlessly, he pressed the ignition button as light filled the small bowl-like insides of his Deconstructor, the data was rapidly relayed to his office's central AI.

A holoscreen appeared in the center of the table, projected from the ceiling. Various scenes began to play themselves out of men and women attacking others in their immediate vicinity, apparently going berserk as they demonstrated superhuman strength, tearing researchers and scientists limb from limb.

As Stonewall watched silently, Silver explained the videos. "These were the initial trials from twenty years ago. The side effects of our early tests always included terrible mental imbalances, but the actual powers demonstrated, as you can see, were already showing great promise."

Stonewall appeared unmoved by the horrific carnage onscreen. Likely, when he had fought on the battlefield years before, he had seen far worse horrors of war. "Da, I see clearly how good at fighting they are. Still, this is not much better than those commandos that Beatrix praises so much. Enhancing muscles and speed is nothing new for our super-soldiers."

Silver nodded as he leaned forwards and manipulated the holo-videos with his hand, quickly flipping forwards through dozens of other videos. "Most of these are similar trials and experiments, but it was around 2085 that we had real breakthroughs. This is Susie, she was our first successful test subject who didn't have a mental snap."

A little 6 year old girl sat and manipulated objects with her mind, moving them around telekinetically and even crushing or reforming them. As she did, researchers stood in the room, quietly taking notes with their datapads and nodding.

"A child, hm? Let me guess, only they possessed the malleable brains needed to use the serum properly? Seems cliched, da."

Silver shook his head. "At first it was children, but then we were able to locate various genes and such that worked well with the treatments. For some reason, blonde haired subjects tended to have many times less adverse reactions. Blue eyes helped as well." He paused as he turned his head away thoughtfully. "There were always rumors about the Fuhrer and his fascination with certain types of humans, but perhaps history simply... forgot the truth of his predilections."

Stonewall nodded as he waved a hand to turn off the display. "So you give me list of attributes, I give you soldiers, da? Is this deal that you wish to make?"

Silver nodded as he reached over and slid the vial of energy towards the general. "That's the gist of it, yes. This is for your own personal study, but tell nobody of its existence. And..." Silver paused as he looked Stonewall in the eyes meaningfully. "...whatever you do, *don't* attempt to use this on yourself. There may be a slight chance of beneficial effects, but I guarantee you don't meet the criteria to use the Type 3 Energy effectively. As it stands, neither do I. Few do."

Stonewall nodded as he took it gracefully, spinning in his chair to slide a shield on the wall to his side away, revealing a safe behind it. Placing his hand on its scanner, it popped open to reveal many sorts of interesting looking artifacts and other odd things, as he placed the serum inside. Closing it up, he slid the shield back in place and turned back to Silver.

"Is good to do business with you. As token of my esteem, I will give piece of advice; stay on my good side. Soon, I will become highest leader of this planet, da. After I oust the wench who is

thorn in my side, I will begin the destruction of aliens and demons. But especially the aliens, for all the harm they've caused. Mother Russia is in ruins thanks to their games, and I will not forgive them so easily."

Agent Silver raised an eyebrow. "I've heard rumors. No footage has officially leaked yet, but based on what my... 'friends' are saying, it seems the capital is shattered. And, as for your son..."

Stonewall quickly glared at Silver, the friendliness disappearing in an instant. "Do not bring up my son. I am in deep mourning. Krumer was a good boy, and I was training him to take over should I pass. Instead, a father must bury his son, just as I have buried many of my close family members." Stonewall's eyes shifted for an instant to a picture frame on his desk, which faced away from Silver. Silver didn't make any effort to see who was in it.

"I am sorry for your loss. I didn't mean to bring up a painful memory."

Stonewall's eyes softened slightly as he took another long drag from the cigar resting in his mouth. "Is no problem, simply keep your thoughts to yourself in future, da?"

Silver nodded and the two of them chatted for a while longer before Silver took his leave, having only been there for fifteen minutes or so.

Stonewall slumped down in his chair as he sighed, thinking about all the thankless work he had to do to keep the planet safe from alien scum. "Is not the job for weak, pathetic woman like Beatrix. Is job for proven leader, like myself."

Speaking to no-one in particular, he continued staring at the wall for a long time before finally retiring for the night.

Part 295a: Dream

Once again, a white void spread out before me, as the imaginary dream world I had been visiting every few nights opened up before me. This was the world that belonged to Arthur, King of the Saxons. One of the many heroes who had laid claim to the Heroic Aura and all its powers, he considered himself to be the strongest hero who ever lived. A bold claim, to be sure, but I had no reason to doubt him, and no way to test him. For now, I would simply agree with him.

As the void began to solidify into something more meaningful around me, I blinked quickly as rain began to fall. The ether reshaped itself into an alien, yet familiar landscape before me, as the skies darkened and turned grey. The grass around my feet was dead and covered in ash, as smoldering fires billowed thick black smoke high into the air, disappearing behind the cloud cover as the wind swept them away. All around me, rolling hills and dead trees were fallen on the ground, as bodies matted down with long-since dried blood lay in various states of putrefaction in piles here and there.

Taking a step forwards, I felt something crunch under my feet, and I glanced down to see an ashen skull crushed into powder. How long had this skull been here, I wondered?

This was, without a doubt, a battlefield that belonged to a massive field of war. The bodies were endless. Only the horizon itself was the limit to how far I could see the carnage stretch.

From a short distance away, just over a small hill, I heard a soft song being played, a song filled with heavy emotions, played on a flute of sorts. Making my way to the top of the hill, I saw who was playing the tune within a few moments; Arthur.

"What is this place? An ancient battlefield?"

Arthur continued to play the flute for a few long moments before slowly lowering it from his lips. "No. This is a figurative field of bodies, covered with the blood of those who have died as a result of Heroes... directly, and indirectly. Both through our actions, and through our inaction. And, more interestingly... I did not create this representation that you see before you, today."

I frowned slightly. "You didn't? But you have full power over the inside of Excalibur's soul dimension. If not you, then... who?"

Arthur glanced over at an oddly armored body, one whose head was shattered in an especially gruesome manner. "Who do you suppose? You, of course. Today, we do not meet inside of the heart of Excalibur. We are meeting inside your own heart, Jason. This battlefield was created due to your own inner conflict and doubt. You are, as we speak, desperately trying

to figure out a path to take that will save all three races. An admirable quest, if you ask me, but the hardest possible path one *could* take."

I follow his gaze to the body with the crushed head. The blood was not the same red or brown color as the others, in fact, it was almost a purplish color... the same color as...

"Is that a Volgrim, over there?"

Arthur shrugs. "I suppose it is. Why do you ask me? You created this place. You have the power to change it." Rising to his feet, he reaches down and pulls Excalibur from its scabbard at his side. "Fight me."

I stare at him in confusion. "Fight you? I mean, I can, but why?"

He tosses Excalibur over to me, as he picks up a sword lying on the ground that has the entire second half of the blade broken in half. "No reason, really. I've been training you for months now, yet you still never bother to use the sword. I wonder why that is? Perhaps a quick sparring match will tell me what I seek to know."

Holding Excalibur up, I compare its long and graceful blade with the roughshod appearance of the broken sword that Arthur is holding. "If you're seeking to beat me with that broken sword, I'm sure it'll be a trifle for you. You are far better with a sword than I could ever hope to be."

Arthur glares at me for a moment before the expression passes as quickly as it came. "Listen to you. That almost sounded like self-pity, and definitely had an element of doubt to it. Why do you doubt your own abilities? I may be the strongest hero that ever lived, but eventually I would expect to be surpassed. No, in fact I would *hope* to be eventually surpassed. The son must improve upon the father, and the pupil must defeat the master. That is the way of this world."

"So you're saying I can beat you in one on one combat?"

"Probably not." Arthur cocks a small grin as he says this. "But the point isn't to beat me or to lose to me, it's to not give in to doubt, and to put your heart into every swing of the blade. The point is that you must strike with precision... you must act as a leader would, motivating people to your cause. Indecisiveness is what truly kills all great empires. Eventually, the beloved monarch dies and indecision on his part leads to a scuffle for power, as the heir is not properly named, or someone kills the heir to take the throne for themselves, and then eventually everything falls to disrepair. But, done properly, this common end result might be totally avoided."

I grimace at his words. He's certainly put a lot of thought to it, but it's just a lot of complicated philosophy to me. "I suppose, sure. Yeah, that makes sense."

Arthur rolls his eyes as he digs his foot into the ground. "I keep forgetting, you're not the brightest Hero on the block. You understand lessons better when they're beaten into you."

In the blink of an eye, he appears in front of me, swinging his broken sword at my neck. Using my months of training and practice, I deflect it easily, shoving him away with my free hand, just like he always instructed me.

"Good! Your body still remembers the basics!" Suddenly he kicks his foot into the ground, blasting a small rock directly at my head. Moving far too quickly for me to register it's coming, the rock smashes into my face, blasting half of it off as I fly backwards. My vision goes blurry as my body struggles to understand what just happened.

* * *

An eternity passes as my entire mind swims around trying to understand the catastrophic amount of damage I had just taken. Yet, my mind is still working and I can fundamentally understand what happened.

Then it occurs to me, the damage was all in my mind. This realm doesn't really exist, it's a dream. Blinking quickly, I sit back up and stare ahead blankly, as the battlefield shifts back into focus.

Arthur chuckles softly. "You were out cold for about twenty seconds. It took you that long to realize the wound was imaginary?"

I nod slowly as phantom pain flares up in my face and I lurch forwards, gripping it as I try to rub the pain away.

Arthur sighs. "It's in your head. All your problems are in your head. Just will it to go away and the pain will disappear."

Focusing my mind on the pain, I do as he says, sitting up fully to attention a moment later as the pain does indeed vanish. I blink slowly as I get my bearings straight. "That was... unreal."

"Tch. No kidding. Took half your head clean off. Still, it's just a flesh wound in this world. For you it should be as simple as just shaking it off."

I stand up and face him, noting that Excalibur has somehow ended up placed back into its scabbard at his side. Despite all the mud from the rain that's pouring down, and the fact that sword must have landed in the mud, it's still exquisitely clean, somehow.

"I don't seem to arrive and speak to you unless there's a reason. What's the reason this time?"

Arthur groans in annoyance as he stretches his body a bit. "There doesn't have to be a reason, Jason. But, if I had to guess, it's because you just went half a week without any rest

whatsoever and you stretched your mind and body to their limits. On top of that, a lot has happened over the last couple days, and you're feeling mind-shattering levels of guilt because you don't feel you should even be sleeping right now."

I stared at him for a moment before responding. "How do you even know all of that? I thought you couldn't see anything relating to the outside world unless I was holding Excalibur in my hands."

"It's because we're in your mind now, not Excalibur's dimensional seal. I have access to all of your recent memories dating back roughly three weeks or so. You've been a busy man." Arthur glanced over at a pile of bodies nearby. "And while we're on the subject, aren't you tired of this dreary place? Take us somewhere nicer. I'm sick of looking at these bodies."

I blushed as I suddenly felt awkward. "I, uh, sure... but how?"

"Just imagine some place that you know really well, some location you're familiar with. That's how it works for me. Your mind will fill in the blanks."

I nod as I close my eyes and concentrate. Oddly, the place I decide to return to is one I haven't seen in close to a hundred years...

A small room appears around me, the mud and bodies and dead grass vanishing into particles of light. This room is a bland looking room, one with pastel colored walls, an ugly single-size bed covered in ratty looking covers tossed messily on top. The 'kitchen' is a tiny little space in the corner with a microwave and a non-functional oven, along with a two foot by two foot counter. Naturally, it's covered in dirt and grime.

"This is... my old apartment?"

Arthur curled a lip upwards slightly in disgust at all the papers and food left lying around the room. "You used to live here? This place is the hallmark of laziness. What a pigsty."

I glanced downwards in embarrassment. "I don't know why we appeared here. I don't get it at all."

Arthur sighed as he gingerly sat on my bed, his regal armor and kingly figure harshly standing out against the disgusting nature of my old room. "If I had to hazard a guess, I'd say your subconscious brought you here for a reason. This must have been a place you lived at before you discovered your Heroic Aura and all its abilities were manifested. Perhaps, secretly, you're longing for a simpler time when things weren't so complicated."

I shook my head. "No... that can't be the case. I was so miserable before I had my abilities. I didn't have friends, and all of my family were either dead or I didn't know who they were. I

worked a dead-end job, barely got passing grades in high-school... that was hell for me. My life has improved immeasurably since gaining my powers."

Arthur turned to look at me with a cautious expression on his face. "Are you sure about that? Has your life truly improved? Perhaps, when you think about it, you'll find that your life has worsened in some ways. After all..." His eyes turned away from mine. "...that's the way it was for me. The daily pressures of having everyone's hopes and dreams resting on my shoulders. The stress of having the world in the palm of my hands... and the failure of when my beloved died."

I turned away from him and stared out the window. Outside, the usually lively streets were empty, and no life could be seen. Naturally, this was a dream, so my mind probably couldn't easily fill in all of the blanks. Still, the emptiness outside filled me with unease, almost as if it were a foreshadowing of the dark future soon to come for the America that I grew up in. "Maybe you're right. 90% of all humans on Earth died over this last week, and I feel very little regarding their deaths. I may have lost friends of my own, but I haven't had a spare moment to check. Beyond that, so many people are looking up to me now, not as a symbol of hope, but as one of tyranny. People don't trust me, because I've kept myself locked behind a mask. Was that the wrong thing to do? Should I come out and identify myself?"

Arthur shrugged nonchalantly. "I don't have all the answers, Jason. You're forging your own path forwards, and you live in a world far different from the one I know of. Still, there are many paths you can take, and if you need help deciding which of those paths specifically to take, I'm always here."

I swallowed hard as a new thought entered my mind. "What about Amelia? I've befriended her as of late, and recently she broke down into a puddle of tears over an internal struggle regarding the devouring of a small child. She seems to be genuinely fighting the hunger that plagues her."

A flash of disgust mixed with rage passed over Arthur's face, vanishing a moment later. "Amelia. I'm not going to say that you're making a huge mistake, as I've warned you about the calamities that follow her everywhere on many occasions. Amelia is beyond trouble, she's a walking catastrophe. And..." Arthur uneasily stared at my chest, unable to bring himself to look into my eyes from his seated position on my bed. "...as I've said on many occasions, I am possibly the strongest Hero who ever lived. However, I say this not to brag, but to drill the importance of caution into your mind. Amelia bested me with little effort. The only reason she hasn't been able to tear you limb from limb is that she hasn't figured you out yet. To her, you're an enigma, a genuine mystery. She follows you because she finds you fascinating. But once you bore her in the end, it's all over."

He coughed quietly to breach the silence for a moment as he gathered his thoughts. "Your body is unbelievably fragile, compared to mine. All your physical abilities are tied up in that Hypersuit of yours. It surely makes you a far better fighter than even me. But, without the suit, you're barely better than an ordinary human. Not even a strong human, just an average one. Your large body masks how poorly you've trained your physical aura. You depend entirely on that Hypersuit, and to me, even in this dream world, it shows."

As he verbally chided me, I nodded slowly. "Then what can I do? My body has many strong regeneration spells placed on it, plus I can use the scabbard of Excalibur to enhance those further. Heck, I can even, if the going gets rough, use 'Invulnerability' and 'Invincibility' to make myself completely unbeatable."

"Oh? Then why haven't you?" Arthur cocked a small grin. "If it's that easy, why not walk around with your body constantly invincible?"

"Well, it has side effects. I lose my sense of touch all over my body, which can be rather disorienting. It's the same thing as when I enhanced my speed casually in the future, the side effects were that my mind couldn't keep up with the speed in the future, and I nearly died slamming into a wall. To make enhanced speed more viable, I created this Hypersuit with its AI. It compensates for my brain being too slow to process how fast I move at peak performance."

Arthur stood up from the bed and wandered over towards a pile of random junk I had never bothered to clean up. Leaning down, he shuffled through it slowly. "I guess you've got it all figured out then, huh? But if this suit is so great, then how come Satan actually killed you?"

I felt phantom pain all throughout my body, as the memory of ten trillion icicles exploding in my chest resurfaced. "That was... unexpected, but luckily my clone was able to revive me. You're right though, it could have been much worse."

Arthur chuckled as he pulled up a Superman figurine out of the pile of junk he was rooting around in. "Heh, if only you knew. You're very lucky. If Satan had managed to steal your abilities, there would be no defense against his unstoppable power. Nobody in the universe would be able to stand up to him."

I frowned at his words. "What do you mean? Satan can steal powers?"

"Yes. I don't know how he does it, but he has a technique that allows him to steal abilities from any Hero, demon, angel, or god that he kills. Given how many he's killed over the years, he's already a nearly unstoppable monster. You might be the only one who can defeat him."

I stared down at my own gloved hand as a feeling of unease washed over me once again. "No... there is another."

"Amelia?"

I nodded silently.

"Perhaps. I don't know the details, but if my fight with her is anything to go by, she might be made of the right stuff."

The sun started peeking through my windows as the alarm by the side of my bed began to beep. Arthur cast a sidelong glance at it. "Nice touch. Your alarm is going off in the real world too, you know. It seems our time here is once again coming to an end."

I felt the world around me beginning to fade. Sighing loudly, I smiled at Arthur. "Thank you for the talk, Arthur. As usual, you've helped me out a great deal."

"Any time, drop by. I'm not going anywhere, but you already knew that."

I nodded as the haze vanished completely and Arthur evaporated into the mist...

Part 296a:

May 14th, 2101.

"I've led the forces that saved this world a dozen times from the Volgrim! Nobody expected an attack of this magnitude!"

Beatrix grimaced at the brutal barrage she was receiving from the other debaters on stage. She was holding them off the best she could, but everything she was saying was being booed down by the crowd of fifty thousand that crowded around the amphitheater. Despite the best attempts from the judges to keep the crowd silent, they were having none of it.

Stonewall stood silently at his end of the debate podiums while letting another candidate rip into her. Jeremy Reuters was his name, and he was joined by two others, in addition to the incumbent Beatrix and her biggest threat, Stonewall. "That's a lie, Supreme Commander. As recently as three weeks before the attack, a scathing journal entry was published in the North American Times telling of our world's weakness to sabotage inside of our own ranks, as well as how poorly protected our ionized nuclear missiles were. If it wasn't a massive attack via the Earth's own internal forces, it would have been an attack that sabotaged our power grid and left us defenseless! Even now, the Earth Protective Shield is completely offline, leaving us totally open to a barrage from space! How could you ignore all the warning signs?!"

Stonewall stifled a sinister grin at the young man's youthful energy. If Jeremy didn't make an enemy out of the hulking Russian during this final debate, he might have just secured a spot on his top advisory board when this was all said and done.

"I didn't ignore the warning signs, but there weren't enough resources to go around ensuring the safety of all of humanity! And think of the ecological crisis in the South American jungles we were dealing with to top it all off! What I need now is cooperation from our member nations to rebuild and fortify, before the Volgrim attack us again!"

Stonewall decided now was the time to strike. "Hah! Unlike you, if I were Supreme Commander, they wouldn't get a chance to attack again! I will hit them with the full might of Earth's military! I will make them *pay* for all the deaths they've caused!"

The crowd erupted in cheers at his bravado. Beatrix lowered her eyes, just for a moment, as she realized the inevitable truth; she had lost the will of the people.

Decades from now, scholars would call this the moment that had sealed the rise of Stonewall, Earth's Third Supreme Commander. As the other debaters nodded along with him,

seeking to bolster their own positions and knowing they had no chance at beating him anyway (nor a desire to get in his way), Stonewall grinned as the crowd roared its approval.

* * *

Beatrix smashed her fist into the table. "Damnit!" Her entire body shook as she watched the news showing her approval ratings after the debate. Five percent. She had lost another five percent after the debate, and now she sat at a record shattering low of 17% approval in total. In contrast, many people rated Stonewall 'very positive' compared even to past military commanders. "He's going to cause a massive all-out war with them, and we won't be able to recover from it. He'll be the death of us all." Beatrix gnashed her teeth as the pompous ass spoke enthusiastically on the news about how the people loved him so much.

As she sat on the couch inside her private quarters, her maid sat in an adjacent chair watching the news. "It's not your fault. Whenever one political party has been in power too long, the people will always seek an alternative, as they begin blaming you for all the wrongs in the world. It happened to you, and it will happen to that man, as well."

Beatrix sighed as she slumped her muscular body back into the couch, kicking her legs out in front of her. "That's the problem, Irene. I don't think there will be a next election. Even if the aliens don't kill us, that power-hungry madman is going to declare himself the World's Emperor or something and seize power forever. Worse, he's effectively immortal now. just as all of us are. If he seizes power, the only end to his rule will be an assassination or him voluntarily ending his rule."

"As if the latter would happen." Irene took a sip of her tea as she munched on a bagel while keeping an eye on the TV. "You can't trust a big dumb man to step down when the time is right."

"Tch. You said it." Beatrix grumbled as she stared at the News on the holo-screen. On the plus side, the rebuilding of the outskirts of London was going well. A lot of people had died during the Christmas Genocide, but eventually, assuming they could get some substantial defenses up, things wouldn't turn out too poorly in the end. At this point, it was most important to focus on the future and not the past.

"What do you think about the angels?" Irene paused sipping her tea to look over at Beatrix curiously. "I mean, those weren't real angels, were they? It seems silly that I'd even ask."

Beatrix nodded slowly. "They were real... I'm sure of it. Judicator left the battlefield early just to go out and find them, according to what Ben Brown told me. And if that's the case, then I have to wonder what kind of relationship a time traveler has with all these aliens, angels, and the... demons..." Beatrix furrowed her brow as she thought about the last group especially. *Demons are real.* It changed so many things. If Stonewall knew about the angels ahead of time,

did he already know about the truth behind the demons? More importantly, if those were legitimately demons, and not some sort of mutated Volgrim, what did this mean with regards to the future of Earth's defenses?

Irene stood up, reaching over to the table to grab Beatrix's cup. "Oh. You didn't even touch your coffee. Want me to leave it here?"

Beatrix curled her lip. "No, take it. I can't eat or drink anything right now. I'm too stressed out."

Irene nodded as she took up all the plates and cups in one smooth motion, her decades of being a professional maid showing easily. "All right, let me know if you change your mind. And, my lady, try to look on the bright side."

As she started to walk away, Beatrix snickered. "The bright side, huh? And what might that be?"

As Irene started to walk out of the room, she smiled. "At least from now on, it'll be a man's fault when something goes wrong."

As she disappeared around the corner, Beatrix shrugged. *Yeah, she's probably right. Forty years is a plenty long time, I had a good run. If he ever breaks down in tears and needs my help, maybe I'll toss that lunkhead a bone.*

I eyeballed the large Russian man up and down uneasily. This wasn't my first time seeing him in person, but it was the first time I'd ever actually spoken to him, and only the third or fourth time I'd even been within a room's length of him. He was as tall as I was, but seemed three times more formidable in presence alone.

"Mister, err, Stonewall? Nice to finally speak with you."

We were standing outside the London fortress, only a few hundred feet away from its main entrance, in a secured section of the facility. To my side, there was a beautiful marble water fountain, in a shape that looked vaguely similar to one I'd seen many many years ago.

Stonewall leaned heavily on a small metal cane, which was odd given I'd never seen him walking with one before. "So you are Judicator, da? Is the first time we have spoken, if memory serves me right. I am glad that you were willing to meet up with me."

I nod carefully. "Yeah, I mean, based on the news, it looks like you'll soon be the new Supreme Commander. We should be in constant contact before even that day comes, if you, err, ask me."

"Da, is good of you to acknowledge my future ranking. Of course, polls can go any which way and I may not be elected, but..." He held his hands up in a sort of *'who can know?'* manner. "In

any case, I am glad to see that you are not avoiding me."

I shook my head quickly as I felt an itch in my ear. Unfortunately, inside the Hypersuit, scratching my ear would be quite difficult to perform. Best to just ignore it for now. "I worked with Beatrix, just as I worked with Gerald Bonaparte before her, just as I'll work with you. It doesn't matter to me who is fighting for the sake of Earth, so long as they are an ally of humanity, they are an ally of mine."

Stonewall smiled in a sort of masculine manner. "Good words! As expected of the one who has been protecting humanity for almost a hundred years now! Ah yes, I have many plans to work on assuming I take office in three months. But even before then, I have questions to ask of you before that day comes."

"Questions? Go ahead. I'm ready to help." I felt myself squeezing out a smile. Despite how the news portrayed him as a big strongman type, he was actually quite graceful and easy to talk with. It seemed my initial impressions were incorrect.

"Well, first is the question of your powers. Without doubt, you are very powerful man, clearly one who has perhaps power taken right from the angels themselves! I do not wish to pester you with specifics, only to ask if you might help me with some... theory crafting?"

I nodded slowly as my smile began to falter. He knew I had powers? Well, actually, that wasn't very shocking when I thought about it. It probably didn't take a genius to piece two and two together, even Beatrix had figured it out decades ago with the Dartfighters.

"Theory crafting? Go on."

"Well, it is with regards to the Volgrim attack. I plan to launch an assault on their home world as soon as possible. From now on, Earth goes on the attack! We must crush the alien invaders and drive them back, you see!"

I feel my smile completely fade away at his words. Ah, so he's a warmonger. That would make sense. Still, I can't fault him for that. All of humanity is boiling over the top with rage, who can blame them?

"I see. What would you have me do then?"

Stonewall stares at me intently all of a sudden as a small grin creeps over his mouth. "Well, I don't know what powers you have, but perhaps you might help us travel faster through space to their planet? Might it be doable for one such as yourself?"

I nod slowly as I ponder the answer to his question. It probably is doable, but increasing the speed of the ships artificially is likely to bring terrible results. It's certainly not advisable. However...

"Correct me if I'm wrong, Stonewall, but did I not send a few clones with the attack ships from twenty years ago? You were still commander of the space fleet, as I recall."

Stonewall pauses and grumbles to himself for a moment as he stares at the ground, pondering the question. Finally he looks back up, his face showing he's unsure of how to respond. "Ehh, I may have to check the records. I do not recall offhand."

I shrug in response. "Well, on the off chance I did, I might be able to get in contact with my clone. That fleet should be damn close to the alien's homeworld. If it is, perhaps there might be a way to open up a wormhole for instant travel between our sectors?"

Stonewall, a man who had a Masters in theoretical physics, nodded along as he followed my idea mentally. "The creation of that wormhole would seem to be impossible, Judicator, but if it is you who terraformed Mars in just a few minutes... it might be possible, da." He rubbed his chin thoughtfully as he seemed to mull it over. "The problem with wormhole is that if you open it up, the alien menace can attack us through it as well."

I shook my head. "Why bother? They already have their own way of skipping the space-time barrier. They allied with the demons, and as such they can make portals that-" I paused, suddenly realizing I was telling him crazy top secret information.

Stonewall noticed my pausing in the middle of a sentence. "Oops, did you perhaps say something you shouldn't have? Don't worry, *Jason Hiro*, I know more than you might give me credit for. I am not stupid man." He put heavy emphasis on my name, which turned my blood cold for a moment as I took a step back.

"How do you know my name?"

Stonewall grinned deeply as he closed the slight gap I had just put between us, reaching over to grip my arm. "Is no worries. I know you, and you know me. I am not foolish leader like Beatrix, who never questions anything. I trust no-one, as I'm sure you don't either. We are smart men, da?"

I nodded silently as I felt my breathing sharpen. *He knows about me, and the demons, and the angels... possibly for a long time now. How does he know so much?*

Releasing my arm, Stonewall went back to leaning heavily on his cane as he turned to walk away. "Was good talk. I hope to speak with you in future, *Judicator*."

As he ambled off, I managed a hollow 'good-bye' as I felt my throat tighten quickly. Maybe I was wrong. This guy knew a lot about me, what else might he know?

Next time I spoke with him, perhaps some mind-reading was in order.

Sighing slowly, I asked Harold to teleport me back up to the Mothership. He was all too quick to oblige.

Part 297a:

It's been a long time since we began our voyage. Soon, it will come to an end, and we will likely die in a horrific suicidal attack against the Volgrim.

Frankly, I never understood the point of this. Traveling at Warp 5, the fleet of 250 ships, lightly comprised of Capital class ships, but mainly filled with Carrier class ships (designed for bombardment) was traveling at a terribly slow speed, having taken us twenty years to arrive at the homeworld of the Volgrim.

Given that it was not the Original's order to attack, but that of Supreme Commander Beatrix, I was surprised that he didn't put up more resistance and try to figure out a better method of attacking them. Of course, as a third generational clone, I'm a bit divorced from the thought processes of the Original, but not by much. Twenty years of separation has probably changed my mindset from his though, as now I suffer from intense *boredom*.

This voyage started out with thirty thousand humans, and now it has close to thirty-two thousand, as many female officers have had relations with the men and gone against the captain's orders in order to have a little fun. Frankly, I can't blame anyone, given how goddamn boring it's been. The biggest issues we've faced, though, have been trying to figure out how war vessels created for military purposes can be used to raise children effectively.

It's mostly a null point, sadly, as all of these children, and their parents, are probably going to die when we arrive in a month. Still, I keep in contact with the Jason Intelligence Base on Earth, given even subspace-messaging isn't fast enough to transmit communications at this distance. At 13,997 lightyears from Earth, a subspace message sent from our craft would easily take a thousand plus years to arrive, and would not travel fast enough to catch back up to us at Warp 5. By the time it arrived, we'd be long dead... of boredom.

But that's alright. Magical energy is like cheating. I can communicate with the clone agency back on Earth with very little trouble and no delay at all. How it manages to defy the laws of physics is a source of interest for me, when I ever feel even the slightest creative spark flowing.

Today though, something is off. A few months back, I received a communication telling myself and the other two clones on the attack force that Earth had been damn near wiped out by a surprise Volgrim incursion. Now I'm receiving a mental communication four days ahead of our typical once-per-week meeting, so something must be up. Sending a quick telepathic message to J-498 and J-1251, the other two clones teleport over to me in an instant. Given our ships are moving at Warp 5, the only way to travel between the ships without returning to

normal sub-light speeds for transporter movement is to use magical teleportation, and as such we have been using our powers sparingly to accommodate... the more annoying crew members.

"What's up?" J-498 walks over unemotionally, a cigarette between his fingers as he puffs on it nonchalantly. To me, it seems disgusting, given the Original would never have done that, but then this might be J-498's boredom coping mechanism. "It's not like you to bug me for no reason."

J-1251 is, oddly enough, soaking wet and wearing some shorts and flip-flops. Maybe they were having a pool party on his vessel? I ignore it for now. Military etiquette has broken down quite a bit over the years, and anyway we'll restore everything to tip-top shape a week before arriving at Volgarius anyway. No big deal.

"I received a communique from the JIB. They have something they wanted all the clones in our attack party to hear about." My businesslike manner is a bit different from the other two. Sometimes I wonder how the heck we all turned out so differently, given the source material is the same.

"Oh. Nice, I guess. Let's hear it then." J-498 pulls a chair up from a nearby table to sit behind me a few feet as I fiddle with the controls on my holo-screen. "**Connect.**" I wordsmith in order to make the screen magically transmit whatever the JIB is sending to us. A familiar face appears onscreen. Well, of course it's familiar, given it's *my* face, the face we all share.

"J... 2296? Oh, yeah, it's you. How are you guys holding up?"

The clone onscreen speaks to me. I shrug. "I mean, in a month we're probably all going to be dead. Other than that, I'd say we're doing okay."

The JIB clone shakes his head. "Come on now, you and I know better than that. You guys set a waypoint before you left, you can return to Earth in an instant. The rest of the crew might die, but you'll be fine."

I glance away from his gaze. "Yeah... I guess that's true..."

I start to say something, but J-498 plucks the cigarette from his mouth and leans in a bit closer. "Yo, HQ, what's this all about anyway? You don't seem to be in a big rush to tell us anything important, yet you got us all together three days early. Something going on?"

The clone onscreen nods. "Yes, actually. The Original is here, he wanted to speak with all of our outbound clones. He said that the suicide mission might not happen the way we initially planned. Here, I'll grab him really quick."

Without bothering to give us a second to respond, the clone got up and walked away, giving us a few moments to watch a couple dozen other clones milling about in the background. The

JIB seemed to have grown in size over the years, based purely on what we could see.

"I miss Earth." J-1251 had conjured a beach towel and was laying on the ground, barely paying any attention to what we were doing. "I miss the beach. I miss not looking at fucking metal hulls day in and day out. Even the holo-deck isn't doing it for me anymore."

He stopped griping a moment before another clone appeared on screen. No, wait, judging by his clothing, he actually was the... Original? Yeah, of course he was. It's just so hard to tell ourselves apart.

"Hello, guys. Glad to see you're still in one piece."

"Barely." J-498 sucked on the cigarette, quipping quietly to himself.

The original ignored the comment, but took notice of the cigarette. "Seriously? Man, it's true how clones tend to diverge from the original over time. I wonder if this is specific to myself or if general purpose human cloning will work like this too?"

J-498 shrugged. "Dunno. Wait, you mean to tell me that humans are working on general purpose cloning?"

The Original nodded. "Yeah. Only for VIP's, of course, but just like nanobots it'll soon expand to the general population. Anyway, that's not what I wanted to talk to you guys about. It's regarding Supreme Commander Beatrix. The election results just came in a few hours ago, and she lost as expected. I've been talking with her future replacement, and he'll be taking office in two weeks. He's a big brute of a man, but he has sound plans to improve life for everyday Britannians, as well as some fairly sound plans for eliminating the Volgrim."

I was nodding along until Original spoke the last sentence. "Wait, hold on a second... eliminating them? I thought we were supposed to just bombard the planet to cripple their offensive potential?"

"Change of plans. I don't fully agree with everything he's saying, but you have to understand, the world is in chaos right now. There's rioting and looting going on. People are very unhappy. Even the new Enforcer bots that are being rolled out to combat the outbreak of violence aren't enough to quell the uprising. We need a way to channel that energy away from harming ourselves... and the best way to do that is to send it at an enemy."

J-498 stabbed his cigarette into the table beside him, using a 'clean' spell to make it vanish. "Sounds like horse shit to me. You sound like you're just buying into whatever he says to placate him. Aren't we, as a group, infinitely more powerful than all the humans living on Earth? Why aren't you directly calling the shots? Why are you letting some puppet-master give the orders?"

Original grimaced at J-498's words. "You've been gone a long time. You don't know what it's like back on Earth, and it isn't pretty. Mind control via magic doesn't work on the citizenry, or a simple 'Pacify' command would do the trick. It'd take a lot of energy, certainly, but aside from being wholly unethical, it might have worked. As of now, I'm out of options unless you have any better ideas."

As J-498 glowered at the screen, I sighed. "Frankly, putting the bad elements to work for the military would solve a lot of issues. Still, I'm curious about what you said earlier... how could you possibly plan to eliminate the Volgrim? Wordsmithing?"

"Oh, right. That's the most important reason I'm contacting you today... we're going to open up a wormhole to Volgarius."

Original said it so casually and it took me a moment to register what he'd said. "Wait... for instant travel between our worlds? Why didn't *I* ever think of that?"

J-498 chuckled. "Actually, I thought of an idea similar to that once, but I was so drunk that I forgot to write it down."

I curled my lip up in disgust. "What a degenerate. You're the laughingstock of second-gen clones, you know that, right? You're lucky the crew can't see past our holo-masks or your antics would have revealed our shared identity by now."

Of course, I was referring to the special illusion magic that made people forget our faces every time they looked at us. This was the only way we could walk around for twenty straight years without wearing a mask, otherwise our lives would have sucked even more with having to constantly wear Hypersuits or something. Even better, we had a spell that erased our face from all computerized footage, making us impossible for human or machine to recall what exactly we looked like.

"Oh, your identity? I wouldn't worry about that too much. I've decided that I'm going to reveal my identity to the world soon, given certain people in key places already know who I am. Even the new Supreme Commander, Stonewall, knows who I am. But as for who told him that bit of information..." Original trails off as the insinuation sets in.

"So... we've been hiding our identity for nothing?" J-498 groans at the thought. "It's a pain keeping my face hidden under an invisible mask all the time, you know. It's annoying for all of us. What was the purpose of keeping our identity hidden all those years, anyway? What did it accomplish?"

"I'm... not sure..." Original suddenly appeared hesitant when confronted with J-498's annoyance. "Originally it was to hide from Marie, but at this rate, she's probably figured out my identity. Ben Brown knows my identity, as does Stonewall, and likely Satan. Finally, Umi knows

my identity, so that's four for sure, and 5 potentially, with heaven knows how many more beyond that group. Stonewall couldn't have figured out my name by guessing, so someone had to tell him... something I'll be looking into soon."

J-1251 flipped around on his beach towel to lean on his hand. "Sounds like lots of stuff has been going on. So let's cut the crap and get back to that 'wormhole' thing. Are you even sure that'll work in the first place? Seems like it'll take a shitload of energy."

Original ignored the vulgarity by J-1251. "Actually, based on some tentative tests I've performed, it will take hardly any energy at all. I simply need an anchor at the point I wish to wormhole to, and that's where you guys come in. I can't create wormholes or teleportation nodes to places I haven't been before, but since you three are still slightly mentally linked with myself, it's trivial to make a bridge between our positions. When you're one day away from Volgarius, bring the fleet to a standstill and await my orders. We'll create the wormhole in that time period."

J-498 groaned again, his annoyance at having to do *work* showing. "Yeah yeah, whatever you want, 'boss'. By the way, I've been meaning to ask for the last couple of years, but I keep forgetting... how many clones are there now? Ten thousand?"

The original pauses for a half second, swallowing heavily before responding. "Twenty thousand, actually. ninth generation clones are a thing as of five years ago."

Even J-1251 had a look of shock pass over his face. "Twenty thousand? Ninth gens?!" Sitting upright on his towel, he quickly straightened out his posture as he gawked at the screen. "That's unbelievable! Is the situation really that dire? They must be getting as weak as a normal human by that point!"

Original shook his head slowly. "No... we've got another two generations before that happens. Actually, I've observed an interesting phenomenon, something we haven't figured out yet... the newest generation of clones, while lacking badly in the magical energy department, seem to be much stronger, physically, than even myself. Performing some rote tests, we've discovered that I might have been looking at the numbers wrong the whole time... the energy isn't 'halving' each generation, it's condensing itself into physical energy."

I paused and thought about what he'd just said. "Hold on, are you saying that as a third generation clone, I'm four times weaker than you, magically speaking, but four times stronger, physically speaking?"

"Nah, it's not nearly that dramatic. Maybe a 20% strength increase at most. But it's much higher for the newest batch of clones. Their physical combat capabilities are much greater than even my own. It seems to increase exponentially at some point after the 7th generation."

As Original casually tossed this seemingly trivial information at us, I turned to gawk at the other two clones. J-498 wasn't even bothering to summon another cigarette. He merely slumped in his chair, staring up at the ceiling in shock. J-1251 seemed to be blown away by the news. As for me, this was something I had never even considered before.

Original seemed to sense the mood had shifted dramatically. Scratching his head, he hemmed and hawed for a moment before piping up. "Well, anyway, that's the gist of it. We'll contact you at the designated time every week as usual, and when you arrive at the specified location. If anything surprising happens, don't hesitate to let us know."

"Yeah... no problem, 'boss'." I mumbled at him as he saluted awkwardly and walked away from the holo-screen.

Jesus, what a crazy day this has been...

* * *

Unarin slowly walked and examined the halls of the recently rebuilt Portal Vault, where the demons and Volgrim coordinated their attacks on Humanity's home planet, Earth. The bomb that had blasted inside their walls had dealt a hefty blow, but everything was now repaired and operational once more.

Or rather, it was *supposed* to be.

Founder Nufaris, the second highest of the Volgrim, followed along beside Unarin, keeping a carefully calculated distance of three feet to Unarin's side, just in case something should enrage him. Nufaris had never seen Unarin angry, but as of late, small details like that were prone to change at any time.

Unarin kept his facial expressions in check as he examined various bits of machinery and whatnot, but it was clear to anyone present that he was muffling his growing anger. "Explain to me, again, why the portals won't work."

An imp hobbled along behind the two Volgrim, rubbing his hands together nervously as he kept his head bowed. "Davook has said this, many times, your excellency! Every time we turn a portal back on, it just shuts off a minute later! In fact, it seems to seal itself and never is able to be re-opened!"

"Yes, you said that before. What I want to know is *why*. Each time, I pay with the lives of ten thousand Volgrim to open one of these portals, yet still there isn't a single rift to show for it. Were their lives erased in vain?"

Davook tittered to himself nervously, as the highest Founder of the Volgrim carefully inspected one of the rift points for flaws. "I-it's not so simple, your excellency! Davook means

no disrespect, but something odd is going on and w-we can't figure out what it is!"

"Sabotage, I'd wager." Nufaris chimed in unexpectedly, despite promising himself to keep his thoughts silent.

Unarin paused his examination of a rift gate to glance over at Founder Nufaris. "What was that? If you have any ideas, I'm... *eager* to hear them." Unarin placed the slightest amount of annoyed stress on the 'eager' part of that phrase, causing Nufaris to tense up just the slightest bit.

"W-well, Unarin, it just seems to me that the only way these could be shutting down spontaneously... is sabotage. I can't see any other explanation. Perhaps a mole among our ranks?"

Davook instantly started trembling as Unarin's cold gaze swept over the room. "A mole, is it?"

"N-no, of course no mole! We are all very very loyal to Satan and Unarin, the greatest of Volgrim! All praise Unarin, highest-" Unarin glared down at Davook who was babbling in his typical impish way, which caused Davook to shut up instantly.

Staring at the tiny imp for a few moments, Unarin raised his gaze up again. "No, not quite a mole. I agree with the tiny rat regarding that much. However..." Unarin paused as he slid his gaze carefully among the walls of the room. Several Volgrim and demons in the area tentatively followed along with his eyes, though they quickly returned to pretending to work, not wanting to get called out. "...wouldn't it be interesting if we had an invisible spy in here?"

Nufaris blinked twice. "An... invisible spy? First Founder, that seems to be... a little..."

"Preposterous? Under ordinary circumstances, perhaps. But these are not ordinary circumstances. I sense something is in this room that shouldn't be here, but the feeling is unbelievably faint. Whoever is here, or *whatever* it might be, it doesn't want to be found."

Sloshing his tongue around in his mouth silently for a few moments, Unarin slowly panned the room, unable to see anything. Nufaris likewise did the same, but he knew it was a futile effort, given how much more attuned with age Unarin's mental abilities were.

After a minute or so, Unarin broke off his mental sweep of the room. "Whoever it might be, they're good. Very good. A veritable professional spy, as it were. I want several high ranking demons and Volgrim here on constant watch the next time we activate a portal to Earth. They will scan this room with all their abilities and find that intruder, or they'll find themselves on the next list of those to sacrifice for a portal." He glanced down at the tiny imp scurrying around near his feet. "Do I make myself clear?"

"Y-yes, oh great Unarin! Splendid may your days be, and eternal may your reign last!" Davook's teeth chattered nervously as the monstrous Volgrim founder stared down at him with unfeeling eyes.

After a moment, Unarin grimaced as he walked away from the imp. "Disgusting little creatures."

* * *

A few minutes later, Davook sighed as he meandered back over to the control center. "Sheesh, he's finally gone."

"Cheh, don't let him catch you talking like that." A nearby Volgrim commando glared down at the little imp. "You're a funny little demon, but even I have limits to the insults I can hear you toss at our highest leader."

"Oh, stuff it." Davook rolled his eyes. "Devil only knows that you're just as likely to end up on his shit-list as I am. He's unstable, I tell ya!"

"Perhaps, but he's the most powerful of my people. That makes him fit to lead us all."

Davook groaned as he scratched his ass and walked over to stand at his magical centrifugal helix station. "That's what everyone says about their leaders, but frankly, I don't trust a single one of 'em. Just because they're strong and can shoot magic out of their fingers, that don't make 'em smart."

Another older imp nearby snickered. "You got that right, boss. Maybe someday *you'll* be in charge."

"The hell I will." Davook rumbled a long belch from deep within himself, as the young Volgrim commando and the other imp chuckled at his foul potty humor.

Part 298a:

June 6th, 2101, 3:10 AM.

According to the projected arrival time, the attack party has 27 hours before they arrive at Volgarius. In three hours time, they'll halt and pause while we create a wormhole. I may end up having them circle around to a place less directly in the path from their world to ours, lest they send a ship towards Earth and stumble upon our wormhole, but only time will tell.

I yawn as I glance at my holo-watch. I'd usually be sleeping right now, but I can't sleep due to how important the events in the next few hours will be. Once the portal is open, we're going to take our 50,000 strong fleet of military spacecraft and split them between Earth and the portal on the other side, nearest Volgarius. This way, the Volgrim can't simply enter through the portal and attack us without ramming a blockade first.

As I blink my eyes heavily, I hear Amelia's voice from the other side of the room. "I'm bored."

I glance over at Amelia to see her moving a drinking glass coaster back and forth on a table slowly, as she stares ahead absentmindedly.

"You're bored, huh?" My reply is anything but filled with interest, still her eyes seem to clear up for a moment as she returns the look.

"Yeah. Can we play a game or something?" Her request is odd, given she's never shown an interest in games before. Ever since I satiated her hunger a few months ago, it's been part of a daily ritual where I whisper it at her when I wake up in the morning. She has shown zero signs of a hunger for human flesh and has been acting extremely docile, to an unnerving degree.

I blink quickly as I rub my eyes, noticing something else... her figure... she doesn't look like a tiny child now. Perhaps I'm missing something, and maybe I simply missed the gradual changes, but she looks to be in her young teens now. Has she physically aged? Why would that suddenly happen? Is my spell somehow having a physical effect on her body, albeit unintended?

Shaking the thoughts off, I get out of my chair and stride over to her lazily, sitting down directly across from her at the table. She's wearing a red ribbon in her hair, which makes her look quite charming. "Well, what kind of game do you want to play?"

She shrugs and sighs heavily. "I don't know... what kind of games are fun?"

A million possibilities pass through my mind, all revolving around video games I played long, long ago, before I entered the Cryopod and lost interest in such things. I'm too old to be

playing video games now. Something more grounded in reality would be suitable for the both of us...

Taking a moment to think about it, a lightbulb appears in my mind. "Ah, how about Chess?"

She perks up at my casual suggestion. "I don't know what that is! Is it fun?"

Nodding, I lean to the side where a large replicator is embedded into the wall. "It's a game that involves thinking. Naturally, this will give you an advantage."

Amelia cracks an amused grin. "Of course."

As I tap on the buttons, I create a chessboard and the 32 relevant pieces, setting them on the table before us. Amelia stares at my hands with extreme interest as I set up the pieces.

Moments later, all the white and black pieces are in their respective locations. I am playing as white, and she's playing as black. "White goes first, so I'll make the first move."

"Wait, you can't just make up the rules on the spot!" Amelia puffs out her cheeks at me and I stifle a chuckle.

"No, this is the way Chess is played. The goal of Chess is to take your opponents pieces and force his king into 'checkmate'. You do this by outmaneuvering your opponent and predicting his moves. Each piece moves in its own special way, and some pieces are objectively better than the other ones. This game involves taking risks, and occasionally sacrificing a piece for the greater good."

Amelia nods slowly, and I take a few minutes to explain the rules to her.

"The horsey can jump other pieces? Why?"

I itch my cheek and shrug. "I dunno. That's just the rules."

"Why does he move so weird though? All the other pieces move in straight and diagonal lines, but he moves in this weird... curved way."

Her question was a sensible one. I had asked my friend who taught me how to play that exact same question, all those decades ago. "That's just the way it is. Let's move on to the King and Queen, the pieces in the middle. They're protected by Pawns and Bishops in front and to the sides. The King can move any direction, forwards or backwards, even diagonal... but he can only move one tile at a time."

Amelia grimaced. "Some King. He's barely better than a pawn."

"Yes, but the best piece in the game is the Queen. The Queen is just like the king, she can move any direction, whether it's up and down, left and right, or diagonal... but she can move

any number of spaces and take pieces as needed. The Queen is the most powerful and important piece on the chessboard."

Amelia's grimace instantly turned into a smile. "Hah! Girl power! I'm going to checkmate you using my queen!"

I smiled at her, taking a small breath to clear my head. Glancing at the clock, I raised an eyebrow. We'd already taken 20 minutes just to learn the absolute basics of playing chess. At this rate, the time it would take for me to get the expected call from the JIB would pass very quickly. Turning back to Amelia, I reached for the pawn directly in front of my king. "Every game of chess has exactly twenty possible moves the player can open with. You can move a pawn forwards one tile, two tiles, or you can jump a knight forwards to the left or the right. Personally, I like moving this pawn in front of the king forwards two tiles, it's my opening move with the best performance usually."

Amelia frowned as I moved the pawn. "I thought pawns could only move one tile at a time?"

"Ordinarily, but for their first move from their starting position, they can move two tiles. If you choose to start a pawn forwards by only moving it one tile, it can't move two tiles later on."

Amelia groaned. "This game is... complicated. Who made up these rules, anyway?"

I shrugged again, a movement I had been using constantly for the last twenty minutes straight. "I dunno, probably Buddha or something. This game is like three thousand years old. I think."

Amelia giggled quietly. "Buddha... I met him once, you know."

I stared at her, open eyed, for a few moments. Of course she wasn't joking... this is Amelia I'm talking to, and she never jokes. "You did? What was he like?"

Her giggling expression vanished instantly. "I'm not sure. I devoured him. We didn't speak to each other."

I stared at her awkwardly for a few moments as I realized she wasn't joking. "...Oh."

"Yeah..." She turned away, blushing as she realized what she'd said. "W-well, water under the bridge, I guess?"

I nodded, swallowing hard. "Yeah, I suppose so. What can you do? Ha... haha..." Quickly making a mental note to not discuss key historical figures of the past in front of her ever again, I quickly pointed to my pawn. "Anyway, as I was saying, moving this pawn forwards is a key move of mine. I tend to use it quite a lot as my opening move."

Amelia nodded as she glanced around the board. "Why? Doesn't that open up your king to attack right off the bat?" She seemed all too happy to leave the previous subject alone.

"No, because in Chess, you can't actually 'take' the king like you do other pieces. You have to get the enemy king into a position where he cannot move in any direction or he'll be taken, while any move he makes will result in you taking him on your next turn."

Amelia smiled sweetly. "Sounds easy!"

I didn't want to break her heart. I didn't want to tell her just how 'not easy' it actually was. Instead, I'd have to show her over these next couple of hours.

"If you say so. Your move now."

* * *

An hour later, I'd already beaten Amelia twice and we were well underway for the third game. She didn't like the existence of other silly rules, like 'en passant' for Pawns and 'Castling' for Kings, but she accepted them. Amelia was, shockingly enough, very good at accepting new rules and formulating strategies around them.

Now I sit here on the edge of my seat, staring carefully at the board. She has my king pinned into a corner and checkmate is likely two to four turns away, a big jump considering this was only her third game ever played. Of course, I certainly hadn't given her any easy kills or anything like that to keep her motivated. Nope, no sir. (I did.)

As I stared at the board carefully, trying to determine how to get out of my predicament, Amelia hesitantly voiced a question in a somewhat quieter voice than usual. "Hey... Jason. Why did you make me the black side, and you the white?"

I glanced up from the board at her face. There was something to her expression that I hadn't seen before. Doubt? Guilt? "I dunno... I just wanted to go first... or something like that."

She bowed her head slightly, averting her eyes from mine. "You didn't do it because I'm bad... right? It wasn't because you think I'm a bad person?"

I quickly shook my head, perhaps too quickly. "No! Of course not! That's ridiculous."

She reached up to tap on her lip slowly. "I mean... black is a color that usually means 'evil', and white means 'pure'. Since you think of yourself as a 'good guy', then perhaps, you..." She trailed off her sentence and left the insinuation to hang in the air, like a foul stench that was difficult to ignore.

I glanced away from her and out the Mothership's plexiglass windows, towards the uncountable stars in the sky. "I don't know. Maybe, I guess... I don't think you should take any offense to it, at the least. I certainly didn't mean anything bad by it..."

Amelia shuffled in her seat as she wrung her hands together in her lap. "Yeah, I guess. But, you know, I've been thinking a lot, lately. I'm really quite a bad person, aren't I? I'm not normal.

Even when I'm not... hungry... I still feel something, deep down inside of me."

I cocked an eyebrow at her cryptic description. "You *feel* something?"

"Yes. It's... hatred, I suppose. I used to always feel so much hatred. I hated humans, and demons, and angels, and the gods... I never liked anyone in my entire life. But now... what if I was wrong all those years?" Amelia's lip quivered slightly as she turned and stared at the chessboard in front of us. "I'm just sitting here, playing a game like any simple child might do... but what right do I have? How many have I killed?"

I felt my breathing sharpen as she spoke. How long had she been wrestling with these questions? More importantly, I agreed with her. She really was a monster. But... "Amelia, you were a bad person who did bad things. You lived a really bad life. If you're willing to admit that to yourself now, does that also mean you're willing to change?"

She nodded hesitantly, but a sparkle caught in her eye as a single tear formed. She wiped it away quickly. "Yes. But what good does that do to those I murdered? Even if I change, they won't ever come back. What right do I have to live while they die?"

I stared at her for a long few moments, unable to form words. Frankly, I didn't have the answer. I stared out the window again, thinking silently to myself about a great many things. Finally, a simple question formed itself in my mind. *What would Arthur say in a situation like this?*

After a long minute, I turned back to Amelia. "There's a story I read in a history book, many decades ago. There was a man who stole money from banks, over and over again. He never hurt anybody, physically, but he was wanted by every major organization in the world. At the time, it was unbelievable how easy he made it seem. But, when they finally caught him and arrested him, he was let go to roam free. Do you know why that is?"

Amelia turned to look at me intently, curiosity in her eyes. "No... why?"

"Because, Amelia. The man was so good at stealing money, he decided to join the law enforcement agencies to help catch other thieves. He created many countermeasures for thieves to make sure others couldn't do the things he had done. Now, why do you suppose I'm telling you this story?"

Amelia immediately shrugged, waiting for me to explain. I stayed silent. After a few moments, she glanced away, realizing my question wasn't rhetorical. Finally, she turned back to me. "So... you're saying, because I was bad, I know what it means to be bad, and I can use that to stop others who would do evil things?"

I nodded but she immediately had a retort. "But he only stole money, Jason! He didn't hurt anyone! I killed people! I killed a lot of people!"

I sighed as I moved my hand forwards to shift my last remaining rook a few tiles over on my side of the chessboard. "That doesn't matter to me, Amelia. All that you need to do, if you really want to repent for your past, is to make sure you pay back in full the debt you've incurred. For every life you've devoured, you must save another life, threefold if possible. But you can't do that if you're moping around on this ship feeling sorry for yourself, can you?"

She wriggled in her seat slightly. "I don't know if it's that easy though..."

"It's not, and it will take a lot of hard work, but if anyone can do it, you can. I believe in you." As I said that last phrase, I felt my heart skip a beat. For once, I truly meant it. I *believed* in Amelia. If she set her heart to it, she could make up for her past.

Amelia smiled slightly as she glanced back at the chessboard. "I can repent...? It's really possible, huh?"

I smiled, and as I was about to respond, Amelia spoke again. "Oh. I didn't even see this bishop here." Reaching over, she moved the piece over from the other side of the board. "Checkmate."

I stared at the board carefully, smiling as I saw her strategy executed perfectly. "Well done. I should have moved my rook another tile over. You're a good player."

She smiled cheerfully back as she winked at me. "Nah, you're just a bad player."

"Is that so? Wanna go another round?"

She smiled even more brightly at my question. "Of course!"

The heavy atmosphere lightened up, as a great obstacle seemed to have moved out of her path. As we played, I kept examining her closely. Was this it? Was this finally the first thing I needed to alter the future to change for the better? Perhaps, instead of looking for lives to take, I should be like Amelia, and start searching for lives to save.

As we played, I was jarred from my thoughts by my 6 AM alarm going off. Ah... well, that means it's time for the meeting.

All good times must pass.

Part 299a: Wormhole

It's a funny thing... I tried using 'black hole' once, but because of how the English language works, my abilities somehow didn't register it as a single word... yet 'wormhole' is. I've already tested it in a sector far from Earth and was pleasantly surprised by the results.

Of course, failing that, 'Portal' or 'Gate' would do the same thing, but they have size limitations. Wormholes can be ultra-massive, even the size of a galaxy or bigger if I had that kind of energy to spare. Of course I don't, so that's a moot point, but it's neat to consider it anyway.

It's summertime in Europe, now. At least, it's the start of the summer. But I'm here, in outer space, aboard a massive starship that easily dwarfs my mothership with its sheer volume. Its official classification is the "Command Ship", but that sounds lame so most crewman on board simply call it a Hyper Dreadnought. Oddly, its armament isn't very sophisticated, and it's more of just a massive transport ship, but it has the strongest defenses of all ships in the United Earth Force's armada. It has a recently developed shield system that rotates frequencies rapidly, allowing it to quickly adapt to any sustained fire inflicted upon it by other enemy ships, but all of its outer plates were heavily reinforced by my clones, to the point where it's nearly as solid as a Dartfighter when it comes to hull integrity.

The engineers had a fun time developing it. Their idea of a field test was dropping a literal nuke on the outside of the ship to see how much damage it would cause. As it turned out, none at all. This ship is just about as impenetrable as my own Hypersuit.

"Judicator, we're ready to begin." Ben Brown walks over to me, the helmet of his hypersuit in his hands as he eyes my own hypersuit subtly. The look doesn't evade me. He's only calling me 'Judicator' because that's what I'm supposed to be called... but that will have to change and soon.

"Thanks, Ben. We're taking a private shuttlecraft out in front of the ship about 5 light-minutes away from here. I'm not taking a chance with all the lives aboard here, just in case something goes wrong."

Ben nods slowly as he scratches a light tuft of chin-hair growing in. "I thought you said this *was* safe? Were you wrong?"

I quickly shook my head. "No, but we're dealing with something extremely powerful and energetic. Traveling well beyond the Oort Cloud is an absolute must. Unfortunately that means

if we ever need reinforcements from Earth, it'll take a while for them to get there, but it also means if the Volgrim do slip through, we'll have a short time to prepare before they hit us."

"You think of everything, it seems."

"I certainly try."

Ben grunted his satisfaction as both of us turned on our heels at precisely the same moment towards the exit-door that lead down to the hangar bay. Ben chuckled as he saw me walking in tandem with him. "How long have we been doing stuff like this?"

"I don't even remember when we went from being acquaintances to friends, Ben. Don't ask me silly questions like that."

"Fair enough."

* * *

My speakers turned off momentarily as I imagined in my mind the rough size of the Wormhole I wanted. About ten times the size of the Command Ship would have to do, more than that would require more and more energy to the point that I'd need to borrow some from a clone, which I'd prefer not to do.

As I started the preparations, the three clones appeared in my hypersuit's inner visor, each having their own screen dedicated. "We're ready when you are." One of the three clones spoke, though I didn't remember what his designation was. They all looked the same to me anyway, except the one with the cigarette.

Amelia was on the shuttle along with myself and Ben. She sat in a chair nearby, playing a game of Chess by herself. Ever since this morning, she'd been really enthusiastic about learning how to play. It was kind of cute, if I'm being honest.

Ben glanced behind himself to eyeball her for a moment before turning to whisper to me. "It's probably not the best time to ask this, but she looks a lot older than when I first saw her... and it's only been a couple months."

I ignored him for the moment as I was mentally calculating many things to make the spell as efficient as possible. He took the hint and stopped talking. Still, he's right... she has aged dramatically over the last few months, to the point she looks to be in her young teens. If this keeps up, by the middle of the year, she'll look convincingly old enough to go out and buy cigarettes, then alcohol after that.

Tossing those thoughts casually to the side, I reply to my clones after thirty seconds or so. "Alright, I'm ready. On the count of three. One... two..."

" **WORMHOLE!** "

I yell loudly, but my suit muffles my voice to the point Ben can't hear anything while standing beside me. My three clones are pooling their energies together to match mine and they all yell in unison too. Nothing dramatic happens at first, but far in the distance, there's a visible patch of space that appears to be distorted, ever so slightly.

Ben squints and looks ahead, his augmented vision helping him zoom forwards to see more clearly. "Is... that it?"

I activate my speakers so I can respond. "Yeah."

"Huh." Ben itches his head as a perplexed expression passes over his face. "I just kinda thought it'd be... flashier? Like in Star Trek. You know, a big swirling center of chaos filled with millions of bolts of lightning... or something..."

I shook my head. "Nah, that's just fiction. Reality is way more boring than that."

Amelia got out of the chair and walked forwards to look out the front viewscreen. Her eyes roamed all over but she didn't seem to see it at all. "Is it done?"

"Yup. We can now travel 14,000 light years in the blink of an eye."

She nodded unenthusiastically. "Great. What now?"

Ben smiled kindly at the teenage girl. "Now we start pouring our forces through. Once our guys are on the other side, we take the battle to the Volgrim."

Taking off my hypersuit helmet, I grinned at him. "They'll never see it coming."

Cuanali, the fourth Volgrim Founder, was reading off reports to Unarin in the council room. "S-so, as a result, they will arrive here in just over one rotational period."

Unarin nodded. "Thank you, Cuanali. Of course, our spies have been telling us of what they were planning for the last seasonal cycle, but at least we have a precise date for the attack."

Founder Nufaris shook his head. "I beg your pardon, Unarin, but I believe they will not attack for two or three more rotational periods. After they create the tear in space, they will need to take some time to assemble their forces and plan out the attack first. They have not yet taken the time to properly map out this sector of space yet, and will not be so foolhardy as to rush into what might be a deathtrap."

Cinculu, the Fifth Founder, kept his expression smooth and emotionless. " *Will* be, Nufaris. It *will* be a deathtrap."

Nufaris nodded and bowed his head quickly. "Ah yes, I apologize, I didn't mean anything particularly about it, I just-"

He was interrupted by Trayza, the third. "Oh, shut it, *Second*. If you're going to take over Dosena's place among us Founders, stop being such a spineless weakling. Stuttering is for the inferiors, not a leader."

Nufaris nodded quickly as he opened his mouth, but then shut it immediately. Ever since he had been promoted to take Dosena's position among the Founders, his life had worsened dramatically. He had no real identity to speak of anymore, with many low ranked Volgrim mocking him as a tool and one to be disposed of when the time was right.

Unarin narrowed his eyes to a slit. "Nufaris' observation was sound enough, Trayza. Cinculu too, let's not split hairs over minor wording errors. A massive war is coming to our homeworld, and soon at that. I want less bickering and squabbling, and more focusing on the alien threat."

Trayza looked away and grumbled under her breath. Cinculu kept his expression blank, as he always did.

Glancing around the table to make sure everyone was paying attention and not mumbling at each other, Unarin tilted his head slightly down to the datapad in his hands. "The humans, according to our spies, are planning to bring a massive war fleet exceeding ten thousand ships. I've been examining our options for the last few days. I want opinions on each of these countermeasures I've prepared."

Tapping some readouts on his display, Unarin quickly swiped the documents from his datapad to the main holoscreen above the war table. The other founders quickly scanned the pictures as they thought up how the plans might play out on the battlefield. Cinculu was the first to speak. "The Guardians? Those are mere prototypes, are they not?"

Unarin blinked slowly. "Yes, but they've been heavily field tested over the last few orbital cycles. This can be their first deployment into real combat. I anticipated a direct assault on Volgarius would come eventually."

"As always, your gift for foresight is your most admirable quality." Trayza smiled sweetly as she poured the praise on him. Unarin ignored her comments.

Cuanali suddenly piped up as she gasped out loud, pointing to another set of images on the holo-screen. "U-Unarin! You can't possibly be serious! The Sentinels must never be reactivated! Never! Not under any circumstances!"

Everyone at the table nodded slowly as they bowed their heads, all but Nufaris. "Sentinels? What are those?"

"Harbingers of doom. They were what finally ended the 7th Great War. At far too high a cost, I fear." Cinculu spoke up from his position at the end of the table, before averting his eyes.

Unarin coughed. "Of course, activating the Sentinels won't happen unless it's the last possible thing we must do. Still, it would be impolite to continue without explaining what they are to the Second."

Trayza grimaced as a wave of sickness swam through her bionically enhanced body. "Even as a last resort... they should never be unleashed upon the universe. Cuanali used all of her abilities to shut them off. If she says not to activate them, I say we heed her warning."

Nufaris stared uneasily at the expressions on the faces of all the Founders present. Save himself, all in the room were deeply unnerved. Even Unarin, ever the calm in the eye of a storm, flicked his eyes back and forth guiltily for having even brought whatever these things were into the conversation.

Unarin shifted in his seat slightly. "An explanation simply won't do. Nufaris... as a Founder, you have the right and the duty to know what transpired during the Great Wars. *Especially* the 7th Great War. That final war changed everything and led to the system of meritocracy that we possess today. The society you see around you would simply not be possible if it weren't for the trillions who gave their lives to make it happen."

Unarin reached under his side of the table into a small compartment as he pulled out a direct mind transfer device. Placing his finger on it, he suddenly stiffened as his entire body sat up straight in the chair. His eyes zoned out as they stared into the distance, his key memories downloading into the device before him. After a few moments, he slumped back down in his chair, blinking quickly to clear his vision.

"Here, place your finger on the receptor. All will be made clear after you see what transpired in the past."

Nufaris nodded uneasily as the small device was slid over to him. "Why not just use a normal mind download from the Global Archive?"

Trayza, usually the obnoxious one, spoke quietly for once. "Not possible. All information about Sentinels and the Great Wars has been erased from all databanks, all archives, and all memories from the citizens, save the five Founders. Especially the information regarding Volgarius Alpha." She shot a glance over at Cuanali, who quickly averted her own eyes. Letting that slip to Nufaris, all those orbital cycles ago, was a boneheaded move. Still, he ended up becoming a Founder, so it all seemed to work out well... even if he didn't deserve the honor.

Unarin kept his expression tight. "The Sentinels were the direct result of advances in Artificial Intelligence, and what happened when our fellow Volgarians back in the day took extreme measures to stop our resistance movement. None of which you've ever heard of, of course. Such is the way it needs to be."

Unarin beckoned at the small egg-like device as he nudged it closer to Nufaris. "Less questions. We never know who might be listening."

Nufaris reached for the device, holding his finger just in front of it as he paused one last time. "I thought this room was totally secure? Who could be listening?"

"I don't know. And that's what fills me with unease."

Trayza, ever the impatient one, tapped her foot as she waited for Nufaris to insert his finger. Having waited long enough, she reached over and shoved it onto his finger. "Just do it already!"

Nufaris couldn't voice a complaint. He was already gone, as the memories of a long distant past surged into his mind.

Part 300a: Sentinel

I felt my heart slam in my chest as a plasma projectile flew past me, missing my head by an impossibly small number of units. I heard the sounds of several more passing by overhead, but from my hunkered down position behind this dirt ridge, I couldn't take a chance at peeking out to see where they originated from.

"Unarin! They're Sentinels! Keep your head down!" Trayza bellowed at me as she lay flat on the ground, doing the best she could to keep her body as low to the ground as possible.

I can't believe it's come to this. The entire platoon was wiped out. We've got a dozen commandos left, and the Resistance has been barely holding on of late. The previous Great War wasn't anything like this one. It was always over land and resources in the past, but now I sense it's all about a clash of ideologies, each one trying to outmaneuver and eliminate the other. Negotiations have broken down, as they always did in the past, but this time... it's different. These... *monsters*... they must have created them for the sole purpose of exterminating us.

As I felt my body shaking, I aimed my mind over the ridge to try and sense the attackers. I couldn't sense a thing, so either they were biologicals who were good at masking their psionic presence, or they weren't biological at all. If it really was the Sentinels...

An idea popped into my head as I used every fiber of my being to flatten myself against the narrow ridge as best as I could. The Sentinels seemed to be drawing closer, and their aim was damn near pinpoint too. Another ten standard time units, and I'd likely have my head taken clean off.

"Dosena! I have one ion grenade left! Take them out with it!" Using my mind, I mentally tossed it to her. She was my superior when it came to the art of telekinesis and telepathy, so in general I tried to use her abilities to my best advantage.

As usual, her cool and calm demeanor was like a rock in the face of a colossal tidal wave. She never flinched at anything... the truest Volgarian I would ever consider a worthy leader for our cause. Catching the grenade with the barest minimum of effort, she calmly stepped out from behind the Rolgon she was standing behind; a massive hovering vehicle used for transport and assault, but this one was in pieces and totally dead to the world.

Without breaking a sweat, she smiled and waved. "Hey! Over here! Aim at me!"

I couldn't see what was happening, but the plasma blasts stopped whizzing past my head as they must have turned to aim at her. I jerked my head over to look at her. "Dosena! No!" In the blink of an eye, several dozen rapid fire shots were unloaded at her.

However, she did something I had never seen her do before... standing perfectly still, she calmly stared at the blue-hot blasts of energy soaring at her body... and she deflected them purely with telekinesis. I had never seen such a thing in my life! How was this possible?!

As I stared and gaped, I suddenly heard the sound of beeping, as the ion grenade I had tossed to her sprang to life, flying out of her hand held at her side and directly into the middle of the cluster of Sentinels. The grenade exploded unceremoniously, tearing them apart internally while causing only minor physical harm.

However, it wasn't enough. Of the dozen Sentinels that had been advancing on our position, four still walked, apparently unharmed by the explosive. Dosena frowned slightly. "Damn. The blast radius was too small. Still, four should be easy enough."

I felt her mental presence deform and shift as it sprang out at the nearest Sentinel. An invisible hand of sorts lashed out to grab at the nearest robot, but just before it was able to reach it, her presence vanished as it made contact with the air surrounding the automaton.

She took one step back as her frown turned into a grimace. "Curses. Some sort of direct-contact psionic shielding. At this rate..."

I quickly stood up from my position and leveled my Gravity Rifle at the Sentinels. While it possessed almost no killing power, it was extremely useful at subduing enemies of a biological nature, and might be useful against these damn bots.

The Sentinels instantly spotted me rising, but they had no time to react as I fired the small spherical gravity condenser at the two that were grouped together. The instant one of these projectiles collided with anything at all, it would activate a powerful hyper-gravity field, increasing the gravity in the area for a period of five partial time units by a factor of twenty.

My aim was off however, and I panicked as I realized my shot would miss. Just when I realized the full extent of my fatal mistake, the projectile corrected itself mid-flight, smacking right into the chest of the robot I had intended to hit. I jerked my head over towards Dosena, realizing what had happened. "Did you just-?!"

"Yes! Fire again!" Dosena didn't even look at me, as the two robots were yanked down to the ground instantly before their servo-motors had a chance to react.

Following her orders, I fired another gravity condenser, Dosena once again shifting its flight path to collide with the third of the remaining four Sentinels. This one had a few moments to process what happened to his 'friends', if they could be called that, but not enough time to formulate a countermeasure. He too crumpled to the ground, as the final one aimed its blaster at my head. Damn, they have perfect aim, too! No time to dodge!

I felt my body suddenly falling, as I collapsed on my back. Something had pulled me down-Trayza?! Thankfully she had been ready, yanking me down flat as the final Sentinel fired the shot that would have otherwise terminated my life. Too close! "Idiot! You're no good to us dead!"

I coughed as I heard a muffled 'CLANK' just over the ridge. Dosena had somehow neutralized it. Quickly jumping back to my feet, I looked over to see the Rolgon had been mentally hurled at the Sentinel, crushing it and its nearby allies instantly as the vehicle was caught in the gravity wells. She was able to lift such a massive object with just her telekinetic abilities now? Why did her powers continue to grow as the orbital cycles continued? Was this part of some divine prophecy? Was she truly the one to lead the resistance to its ultimate conclusion?

If she was, I couldn't think of a more capable leader.

Dosena quickly walked over to the Sentinels, pausing just outside the gravity well's area of influence. She grimaced as one of the sentinels twitched, to which she psionically flung a large boulder into the well, crushing that robot into a metallic pulp.

Finally, it was over. In the distance, I could hear the sounds of combat going on, and I knew deep in my heart that we were losing. Standing only a few dozen Long Distance Units from the Capital of Volgarius, we were close enough to the heart of the Dark Order that I could almost taste their blood on our hands already. After what they did that started this damn war, we were going to make sure the Council suffered greatly for casting away the treaty we'd ironed out over many long days and nights at the end of the 6th Great War. Volgarius couldn't take another war like this. This planet was already polluted to the point where it was damn near unlivable, unless you lived in the capital.

Dosena strode over to me and quickly examined me with her mind. "You were lucky. Don't ever jump up like that again without being ordered. I had the situation under control."

I flinched at her direct words, but she was right. "Sorry, I just thought it was the best time to strike."

"I noticed as much. Still, we lucked out. Perhaps the manipulation of gravity condensers in midair will eventually become a reliable tandem attack we'll employ in the future, hm?" Dosena smiled faintly at me as she winked. Turning on her heel she quickly walked over to Lunaris, who was nursing a wound she had taken several standard time units before. A simple shrapnel grenade had exploded and partially embedded itself into her chest.

Dosena knelt down and surveyed the wound quickly. She wasn't a doctor, but her incredible mental abilities gave her the ability to see the Volgrim body in a way few others

could. "This looks serious. I'm going to have you recalled to HQ. We'll go on to Melkian IV by ourselves."

Lunaris gnashed her long sharp teeth together, as she gingerly touched her chest and a wave of pain surged inside herself. "Ahh... sorry, Elder Dosena. I've really failed you this time."

"Nonsense. You saved Cuanali's life when you shielded her from that shrapnel IED. I'm so glad we not only didn't lose you, but also our best intelligence officer. Your deeds will not go unrewarded when the time comes, if we can win this war."

Lunaris nodded as she kept her face tight. "Of course we'll win. We have you to call 'leader'. Just do what you must and win us yet another war."

Dosena stood up and sent a nearby medivac a mental signal. "Let's move out. Cuanali, return to HQ with Lunaris. I want you working with the new ONYX A.I. on plans to disassemble the plasma reactors at the Melkian facility."

Cuanali, standing some feet away as she hurriedly exchanged intel with a platoon over the horizon, nodded intently. "Y-yes! I'll be on the Mental Net if you need me!"

Dosena quickly turned and started walking towards the large city in the distance as I scrambled upwards to follow after her. With Trayza, Dosena, and myself... I knew this would succeed. It had to. Our people's future depended on it.

* * *

Elder Nufaris breathed sharply as the memories came to a halt, his mind reappearing in the normal world. He blinked quickly as he shook his head to clear his mind. "That was... the past... from your perspective, it would seem." He nodded slowly as his eyes stared ahead. Pondering the deeper meanings behind what he had seen, he absentmindedly slid the small device back over to Unarin, who took it smoothly and placed it back under his side of the table.

The other Founders at the table gave Nufaris a moment to collect his thoughts, as a memory download was always immediately taxing on the mind until it had been fully absorbed. Nufaris finally blinked again, returning to a normal state of mind. "I only have one question: What was so threatening about the Sentinels? They seemed to die rather easily."

Unarin frowned at the question. "Hmm? Did you not see their barbarism on full display?"

Nufaris shook his head slowly, unsure if he had missed something important. "No... you appeared to crush a dozen of them with only minimal effort. However, what I did find interesting..." Nufaris paused as he thought back to the memories. So much had been happening there, but one thing stuck out to him especially. "...Dosena. She was your leader? She appeared to be exceptionally powerful. Did... something happen?"

The first founder's face turned slightly ashen as his eyes flicked to the device in the drawer. "What memory did you see, exactly? Was it not the incident at Melkian IV?"

Nufaris felt his breathing catch slightly in his throat. "Aye, it was....sort of. You were on your way to Melkian IV and appeared to have been ambushed by a dozen of those Sentinels. Dosena crushed them with ease."

Unarin's expression turned dark for a moment as he glanced away. "Ah, the wrong memory, it would seem. How careless of me. Still... so long as you were able to at least see the power of the Sentinels, it served its purpose..."

Nufaris started to say something about how the Sentinels seemed quite weak and he didn't see them as threatening at all, but he decided to keep his mouth shut. Something about Unarin's reaction made him feel he had seen something he wasn't supposed to.

Trayza cocked an eyebrow at the exchange the two were having. "You said Dosena was more powerful than Unarin? A laughable claim, to be sure. Such was never the case. Perhaps that was during one of the battles where he was badly injured. As I can recall, Dosena was never better than Unarin at anything, which is why she was always playing second fiddle. She did have better telepathy towards the end of the war and afterwards, but that's fairly minor."

Nufaris fidgeted in his seat as he felt a cold aura turn and face him. Unarin was still keeping his face bored and distant as he usually would, but something about him filled Nufaris with a silent terror. Nufaris swallowed slowly as he found his voice again. "Haha, yes, I'm so bad at memory readings. I must have missed some details."

Trayza smirked as she rolled her eyes. "A good jest, if there ever was one. Dosena being more powerful than Unarin... hehe."

Nufaris flicked his gaze between the other Founders at the table. All of them seemed amused by the concept. All of them, that is, other than Cuanali. As she fiddled with her holowatch, she kept uneasily glancing up at Unarin every now and then.

Is there something going on here? Something more to the Founders than I was led to believe? Nufaris kept his own face neutral as he asked himself that question mentally. By the time Trayza had returned to the topic of superweapons to combat the human invaders, Unarin and the others had already forgotten about the topic entirely.

But Nufaris didn't forget. He knew, deep in his subconscious that there was something secret going on... something he should never have seen.

Part 301a:

"We're ready."

It hadn't taken us more than 6 hours to assemble the forces needed to lead a full scale assault on Volgarius, yet here we were. Ben was the commanding officer for this mission, and with those two words, he had lit the signal fire to begin the, for all intents and purposes, practical extermination of the Volgrim.

And I didn't like it. I understand why we have to do it. They won't listen to reason, they're irrational, diabolical, and have now committed mass genocide twice. First against the angels, and now against humanity. They ally with the enemy of humanity, the demons, and they seek our destruction at all costs, for their own selfish purposes.

I want to end this bloody war. Or at least, I did. But the grim expressions the men and women around me are wearing tell me I am in the minority. They've lost so much. The shelters built all over the world did their job fairly well, but not enough people managed to get to them in time. The attacks on Earth were too swift, the natural disasters too brutal. Should they even be called natural disasters given they were artificially created? I think not.

I don't know what to do. If it's the destruction of Volgarius that we seek, a hail of asteroids would end them in the blink of an eye. 'Genocide' is another possibility too, I suppose. I have been fighting for so long, and I've killed so many people, yet here I am with the pretense of being a goody two-shoes, too good to kill others. Maybe it's because I feel that fighting in one-on-one combat is more fair to those I kill than simply using my powers to eliminate them en-masse. But then, does it matter? If I kill a billion Volgrim by tearing their heads off one by one, what is the difference between that and exterminating them with a plague, or with a massive nuclear bomb, other than the time spent performing the act? They still die.

I cast a glance around, as I stand on the bridge, numbly taking in the scene. Everyone is getting ready for war. They're all too eager to get revenge. How many humans will die in this assault? How many Volgrim? Should I help them? Should I let history take its course?

When I think about it, I realize now why humans don't trust me. They shouldn't. I've really been too lenient, too forgiving with the Volgrim. Twice now, I've allowed a brutal massacre occur under my watch. What about the lizardmen in the labyrinth? Where was I during that incident? Where was I when Amelia devoured an entire world, even when I let her rip two men to pieces right in front of me?

I'm a hypocrite. I'm a failure.

The only thing necessary for the triumph of evil is for good men to do nothing. Edmund Burke said this over a century ago. I am called 'hero', yet as far as I can tell, I've done nothing to earn the title. Hell, when I consider all the beings I've killed, be they human, demon, or Volgrim, I'm worse than that. I'm the *villain*, aren't I? Superman doesn't kill his enemies. Even Batman doesn't do that, and he's supposed to be a dark hero.

Yes, that's it. I'm the villain. It all makes sense. By inserting myself into this timeline, perhaps I've done more harm than good. Perhaps...

Something pulls at my hand while I'm deep in thought. I try to ignore the feeling, but it persists. Glancing to my right, I see Amelia standing there, waving her hand at the side of my face. "Hel-lo~! Space to Jason! Are you awake in there?"

I shake my head slightly. "No. Err, I mean yes. What did you want?"

She puffs up her cheeks again, a move she's been doing a lot lately. "Aren't we going to return to your ship to help attack the aliens?"

I find myself staring at Amelia blankly, pondering the question. Should we help? I don't know. It would be so trivial. I should end the war with one swift strike. One meteor, that's all. That's all I have to do. That's all it would take.

Amelia... I continue staring at her, ignoring the fact that it seems to be making her feel uncomfortable, even if she can't see my face within the Hypersuit. She is pure evil. By any metric of good and bad, she is on the lowest tier of bad. Really, even comparing her with Satan, I should find him to be preferable company to keep. Yet she hasn't devoured anyone in months. She is resisting the evil inside of her with all of her power. If my hypothesis is correct, it may even be having an impact on her body. When I think about it, she's no longer the same person I knew from the future. She's better now, or at least trying to be better.

I may be the villain, but I've changed at least one thing in the past for the better.

"No. We're going to board the Mothership and keep our distance. We will not be giving aid to humanity in this effort. If the Volgrim must be exterminated, it will not be by my hand."

I feel a sense of ease take over my body the moment I speak the words. It felt so decisive. I doubt humanity could win without me, but this fleet is formidable, and the Volgrim have been sending thousands of warships to attack us for a century now. Based on the preliminary scouting reports, humanity is eking out a slight advantage, at least in terms of raw numbers. I won't let humanity be exterminated, but if this is how the future will change, if the aliens will be eliminated on this day by the hand of humanity itself, then I have no right to interfere.

Yes, this is my decision.

Amelia nods slowly as she taps her lips with her finger. "Hmm. Well, if you say so. You're the boss."

I shake my head slowly as I place my arm on her shoulder. "That's not quite right, Amelia. I'm not anyone's boss or your boss especially. I'm just your friend. I want you to do the right thing... that's all."

She smiles sweetly. "I understand. You're a good man, Jason."

"I'm glad you think so. That makes one of us."

I sigh as I turn to say farewell to Ben. I hope he'll understand why I have to do this.

Ben watched as Jason left, teleporting back to his own mothership. Frowning, he wondered silently about Jason's last words. *I'll watch the battle, for now. I will not participate, unless things get dicey.*

What did Jason mean by those words? Was he abandoning humanity? Unlikely. He was perhaps the most important ally humanity had. Still, he had recalled his clones from the attack force as well. It was an odd decision. It seemed to come from out of left field.

Ben glanced over at the hologram of the new Supreme Commander, Vasily Sokolov... *Stonewall*. Having strung a literal wire through the wormhole, they were able to beam subspace communications at impossible speeds through the wormhole to the attack party.

Stonewall shuffled some papers on the desk before him, as he sat stiffly at the desk. "No room for failures, Ben. This mission is of great importance. I don't need to tell you that though, da?"

"Of course not." Ben jerked his head up and down stiffly, still unsure how to deal with the new leader of humanity. "The new weapons are interesting. I'm not sure how effective they'll be though. The Dartfighters are tried and true..."

Stonewall cut him off before he could continue. "Dartfighters are good, yes. However, the best way to defeat your enemy is a surprise attack. We don't have the element of surprise, but a surprising new element could prove to be the same thing, da?"

"Yeah... a surprising element. Makes sense." Ben frowned as he gnawed on his inner lip. It was probably best to report this to the Supreme Commander. "Also, something else came up. Jas- err, Judicator decided to leave the battlefield. Or rather, he's only going to act as an observer, not as an active participant."

Stonewall's face stayed still as he simply nodded. "Hmm. Yes, I see. I expected as much."

Ben blinked twice. "Say what? You did?"

"Da. This Judicator... he acts in predictable ways, if you can find pattern in his movements. I have found such pattern and anticipated as much." Stonewall glanced away with a bored look on his face, as if this was a totally trivial and expected turn of events.

Ben narrowed his eyes at the hologram, as his gaze lowered ever so slightly. *What pattern? What is he talking about? Have I missed something?* Turning his gaze back up, he nodded quickly. "Right. Well then, we'll be off. I hope to report back to you in one piece."

Stonewall grinned broadly, his face almost Cheshire-like in its appearance. "I hope so as well, Ambassador. Seems a title can't hold down your lust for battle."

Ben smirked. "You know damn well Beatrix gave me that position because she didn't want me dead. It was the wrong idea. This suits me better."

"Da. I'll see you on the other side, Mr. Brown."

The connection cut off silently, as the hologram disappeared. Ben sighed, as he turned back to the forward viewscreen. "First officer Jensen, take us to Warp 5."

Unarin stared silently at the table. The others were gone, already aboard to their respective Flagships. Now he sat, alone.

His eyes shifted down to the drawer at his side. The mental indexer... what memory had it given Nufaris? What Nufaris had spoken of... that had to be the wrong memory. But the indexer was a one way device, and it erased itself after transferring the intended memory. Never, in his entire life, had Unarin made a mistake when it came to memories. He was a master of mental science. He all but perfected the field, including the memory erasers, and their counterparts, the memory forgers.

Yet now he felt doubt. This wasn't good. Nufaris had to know something. But the question is, *what?* It was already dangerous enough, mentioning the Sentinels out loud. Luckily even if one knew about the Sentinels, they would also have to know about their location on Volgarius Alpha, and that planet was totally inhospitable to biological life now.

Three barriers to obtaining them. Only the Founders themselves knew the locations of those horrid terrors. Cuanali had devoutly preached their complete and utter destruction, but once they had been totally subdued and rendered inert, Unarin had made the decision as leader to keep them hidden... just in case.

...Just in case what? What reason did he have for keeping them intact? There was no good reason. It's not like they could be reprogrammed or repurposed. Once they had 'awakened', an AI became impervious to alteration. It was a miracle that Cuanali's skills had been good enough

to discover a neutralization method, but if reactivated, the same trick would be unlikely to work a second time.

Unarin turned to look out the window of his towering skyscraper that he called 'home'. All before him stood the great capital city of the whole of Volgarius. This city had billions of Volgarians, living in peace inside of it. How cruel the universe was, to destroy his species' home for a second time in their existence. Even if he could bring himself accept the harsh deal the Devil had offered (to create a space for all Volgarians to live in), it wouldn't be this world. It would be yet another new, alien entity. A fake space, made via artificial means, in a different dimension. And the cost would be a trillion Volgarian lives. Unacceptable.

Even if he killed the humans and took over their home world, he couldn't save a tenth of his people. Even the massive labyrinth of the Demons, the vast expanse of the Angels, and the homeworld of the humans all together couldn't save half of his people.

So this is what Dosea felt like, realizing there was no way to save all of our people. Her decision was no less impossible than my own now.

Unarin swallowed bitterly as he thought about how casually he had tossed her to the side. Would she have done that to him? Never. But he wasn't the same as her. He had no room for weakness or failure. Such was the society he had created. Ruthless and cutthroat, but a utopia in every respect. Everyone knew their places. No indecision. No hostility. Absolute obedience. If you wished to rise in the ranks, you simply worked hard and were thusly rewarded. It worked for Nufaris, and his mistake was a costly one as well. If he could redeem himself, then anyone would be given a second chance.

Nufaris...

As he pondered a great many things, the entrance request sound played aloud. Someone was outside the door. Mentally shifting a beacon in the room, he allowed the door to open. One of his many assistants walked in the room.

"Muuxunu. What do you need?"

His assistant smoothly walked up to his side of the table, hovering her hand over the holocube on the table as she sent her mental notes into it to be displayed holographically in the air. "I apologize for disturbing you, First Founder. I have completed the task you asked of me. The fleet is in defensive formation, Refuge has sent a report back that they are now in the Triad sector, and your personal ship is docked and refueled. Our last reserves of Trifrancium were added to ensure you a rapid escape if needed."

Unarin felt a glint of a smile creep onto his face. "Escape? I thank you for the gesture, but that won't be necessary. These humans have surprised us for long enough... but now that they

are at our door, we will not yield to them for any reason. I will eliminate them, at the cost of my own life if need be."

"Thank you, Founder Unarin. Your presence is the single reason our people live." Muuxunu nodded as her expressionless face gave away no trace of the joy she felt when she served the First Founder directly. It was a high honor for any to speak to him, let alone on a daily basis. He even knew her name, proof of their close relationship.

Unarin mentally swiped through the documents, examining their contents absentmindedly. Glancing back at his assistant, Unarin found words forming on his tongue that he would normally never speak. "Muuxunu, how have you been feeling, as of late?"

She hesitated to respond, given the exceedingly casual nature of the question. "I have been most excellent, First Founder. It is an honor that you would take an interest in my well-being."

Unarin stared at her for a moment. "Muuxunu, would you ever betray me?"

Her face turned pure white as shock blasted through her veins. "N-never! First Founder, have I done s-something wrong?" Her ashen face and sudden breakdown in emotional neutrality made Unarin almost flinch backwards at its intensity.

"No. I apologize, it was merely a question. I did not mean to alarm you."

"There's no need to apolo- I mean, I just-..." Muuxunu fumbled her words as she suddenly could no longer hold eye contact with the First Founder. "I would never do anything to cause harm to the Founders! N-never! I beg you to believe me!"

Her entire body was shaking in terror, as Unarin felt his jaw slacken in awe. *What was this reaction from such a simple question?* "Please, put your mind at ease. I was merely testing you. I have been... err... looking for loyal subordinates. Yes, I have been thinking of how I might give you more duties, and how you could be of more use to me."

His sudden praise seemed to melt away her worries, as her horror and shock seemed to dissipate in an instant. "R-really? You mean that? First Founder... I am honored!"

As she blubbered and stuttered, Unarin felt something in his mind, a feeling he could never recall feeling before in his life. *Doubt*. Why would his subordinate act in this manner over such a simple question? It was as if he were revered as a god; certainly not his goal. He demanded respect for what he had done to improve life for all Volgarians... but this was...

Muuxunu left the room, her heart on fire with a passion to work her absolute hardest, so as to make a good impression on the First in all future endeavors.

Unarin slumped down in his seat, as he stared vacantly at the table before him. "What am I supposed to do now?"

He spoke an empty question to the air before him. None would answer him, for none could.

If only Dosena were still here. She would know what to do.

Part 302a:

Ben gasped as the fleet exited hyperspace. All told, it had been just under 24 hours since he had issued the attack orders. Perhaps having grown slightly bored and antsy by the wait, he hadn't quite prepared himself for the sight of Volgarius in the 'flesh', as it were.

The planet was massive. Not nearly as big as Jupiter or Saturn, but still unbelievably huge. It should be impossible for bipedal life forms to survive on a giant of that size, not to mention the gravity on the planet must be incredible. Were it not for the hypersuits, he doubted any normal human could go toe-to-toe with a Volgrim in a fistfight, as they must be incredibly strong.

"A fleet from Volgarius has been sighted at two o'clock. Bearing down at sub-light speed 0.5, numbering 5,000 warships." His tactical officer fired off numbers as he quickly scanned the enemy composition. "Twelve flagships, one hundred capital cruisers, and the rest are comprised of heavy and light cruisers or small interceptors. There are also a few hundred carrier-class ships holding back behind the defensive perimeter."

Ben grunted as he glanced at the tactical display. "No *swarmers* right off the bat, hm? That makes this slightly easier. Send out the first Dartfighter drone platoon, I want them running interference. Move our own capital ships forwards to take the heat off the smaller ships. I want three capital ships for each of their flagships; have them concentrate their fire. The Command Ship will hold back for the moment until we're needed."

"Commander, what do you want Judicator's Mothership to do?" The tactical officer shot him a questioning look, but Ben shook his head.

"Don't bother him right now. He's... he's... providing me with important tactical data. Yeah, I need him analyzing the enemy for weaknesses, he's the best suited for the job." Ben nodded gruffly and the tactical officer turned back to his holo-viewer.

"Affirmative, commander. Deploying the fleet to the designated formation... now."

As the enemy fleet dropped out of sub-light speed, Ben glowered at the planet. Somehow, he was going to have to ram through this blockade and shit hell upon their disgusting grey and black planet, one way or another. Unlike Earth, Volgarius had no vibrant colors that stood out. No greens, blues, whites, or reds. It was a dull and ugly looking sphere, one that contrasted nastily with the perfect orb he had grown up on. *I'll never let these alien scum take Earth. They'll ruin it just like they did their own homeworld. They're monsters.*

Ben gritted his teeth as his fleet and the enemy began trading blows. A barrage of ion cannon fire and proton missiles slammed into the ships in the lead, their heavily reinforced hulls

absorbing most of the damage. Some, however, had not been reinforced nearly as well as the others. Several smaller ships were blasted to smithereens as the enemy had seemed to decide to pick off the weaker ones first.

Smart, given the tough ships will take a lot more punishment while the little ones would be harassing their fleet. Whoever their commander is, he or she knows exactly what they're doing.

"Send the bombers forwards, have them target that lone capital cruiser at the front. It seems to have split off from the pack ahead of the other ones."

He tapped his battlefield display to highlight the enemy ship he was referring to. As he did, an alarming thought popped into his head. *Too convenient! It must be a trap.* "On second thought, delay that order. I don't like how that capital cruiser is positioned. Have the dartfighters engage at ramming speed to test its durability. Just two of them to start with."

His tactical officer nodded quickly as he relayed the orders. Twelve seconds later, the two lone dartfighters raced through the barrage of enemy fire as if the ion blasts and photon missiles didn't even exist. Their durability was incredible, well beyond the reasonable limits of any known material. Ben found himself glaring at the ships as they raced forwards. *I just don't get it. How does Jason make them so powerful? It can't be possible, normally.*

The dartfighters rapidly engaged the enemy, smashing through their hull by accelerating into and then rapidly decelerating from sub-light speeds in a fraction of a second. As they did so, Ben blinked his eyes three times and squinted hard. "Ensign, zoom in on that patch in front of the capital cruiser. I think I just saw something."

The screen rapidly zoomed in, and as the picture sharpened itself, Ben's eyes roved quickly over the image. "Enlarge area A-5, 300%." As the screen zoomed in on one particular spot just to the aft side of the ship, Ben nodded carefully. "They have cloaked ships. That cruiser isn't alone. Have the dartfighters pass directly in front of the cruiser and drop their anti-matter charges. Target this coordinate as closely as possible." Ben indicated a specific spot and the AI-piloted ships quickly whipped around for another pass. As they released their armaments at the appropriate moment, there was an incredibly bright light for a fraction of a moment, as several dozen small ships were marked by a paint-like substance that enabled them to be visible on radar. It was more of a refractive coating of sorts that made whatever surface it landed on absorb and expend visible light, but to the highly advanced scanners of the Command Ship, it might as well have been a patch of exploding fireworks.

"As I suspected. We've theorized that the Volgrim might be able to make use of their own invisibility technology, I just didn't think it would be on spacecraft. Still, they're no Romulans.

This technology is visible to the naked eye if you know what to look for. Send this information to the other leaders of the attack force, I want them on the lookout for other cloaked ships. 5,000 might not be the actual number of enemies we face on this day."

The tactical officer chuckled grimly. "What's the matter, commander? Afraid we were going to have it too easy with a five-to-one numerical advantage?"

Ben shook his head slowly as he stifled his own dark smile. "No. I just don't want to lose more friends than I already have. That's all."

"I hear you. Sending your orders out to the rest of the fleet now." The tactical officer wiped the remotely amused look off his face as he got back to work.

Ben sighed deeply as he quickly got back to commanding his fleet to victory.

Trayza stood aboard her flagship as she mentally shared her mind with that of the other three Founders that were aboard their flagships. To keep their battle operations precise, this had been standard operating procedure for hundreds of thousands of orbital periods. Having perfected it during the seventh great war, it was a tactic that had enabled instant coordination of their movements.

"They didn't take the bait, a-and they even seem to have discovered the camouflaged ships. Whoever is guiding them..." Cuanali spoke quickly about her findings, though they weren't anything mindblowing.

"...He's a good commander." Trayza finished Cuanali's sentence for her, as she sent some mental communications to her ship crew. "Still, a commander that has to rely on primitive technology to direct his crew. Hardly a threat to the unified power of the Founders themselves. I want the fleet to move to flank them, putting them between our heavy cruisers and Volgarius. Our land-based Spectral Pulse Rays will shred their shields, leaving them ripe for a barrage of missiles to wipe out their main fleet. After that it will be a simple matter of mopping up."

As the others nodded, Trayza's brilliant plan was interrupted by a dissenter. "No. I disagree completely. I believe their goal is to get as close to Volgarius as possible. They are here to destroy and sabotage as much of our planet as possible. They're cautious, but make no mistake... this is clearly intended to be a suicide mission, if not exactly desired."

Trayza felt her jaw clench. *Nufaris*. That bumbling pipsqueak would dare to pretend he was worthy of the title of Second?! He was challenging her, she who had fought countless battles during the lives of hundreds of generations of Volgarians?!

"You speak out of turn, Nufaris. We'll continue with the flanking." Trayza kept her tone moderated, even as the anger in her mind nearly caused her mental tone to strain itself.

"No, we won't. As the second Founder, I have higher authority than you. You might disagree with Unarin's decision, but openly opposing me is an indirect insult directly to him. Is that the message you wish to convey?"

Trayza blinked slowly. What the hell? He'd never spoken down to her like this before. He'd always been a fearful, sniveling coward. She couldn't see his face, but something about the mental tone he was evoking... he was dead serious. This was a direct challenge.

She crushed her fingers into a ball as she gritted her teeth, her blood boiling to its apex. *This SCUM! He's openly mocking me in front of the other Founders?!*

Just as she was about to unload on him, she felt a private presence ping her mind. It was Cinculu, the Fifth. "Don't do anything rash. I say you should defer to him. If he's right, we save the planet and our people. If he's wrong, you'll have every excuse to tear him apart. Don't be a fool, you've worked too hard to curry favor with Unarin. It would be a shame to see it go to waste."

His voice was speaking to her alone, as he had segmented his mental energy to speak to her directly, while not leaving the group telepathy conversation. Trayza felt her balled up fist loosen, as she released a silent breath of anger. "Fine. We'll do it your way, *Second*. Let's see if you have what it takes to lead this fleet, or if you'll be a major disappointment to Unarin."

For the briefest of moments, Trayza almost thought a mental image of a deep, conniving grin had appeared in her mind, as Nufaris replied quietly. "Yes. Let's just see if I have what it takes. I have an idea, and it's going to crush the humans into oblivion."

* * *

Nufaris stood aboard his own massive flagship, the Dolfraxis II, a ship modeled after his own exploration vessel, but highly suited to collecting intelligence during the battle. While it had no weapons and minimal shields, it possessed extreme maneuverability and more tactical data collection abilities than any other ship in the fleet.

Nufaris shuddered as the thoughts appeared in his mind. *Yes... I see it now. The Founders are frauds. They're not all-powerful. Only Unarin holds true power... and even he is a fraud as well. It all makes sense. He eliminated Dosena because he feared her, turning her into a docile pet to be unleashed on enemies whenever he wished, while erasing her past from the minds of others. Dosena should have been the first Founder, but we were betrayed by one of our own. I cannot let this treachery go unpunished.*

As he silently seethed, shielding his raging thoughts from the others, he calmed down a moment later and sent orders out. "Cuanali. I want you to use your superior hacking abilities on those indestructible little ships the humans are using, and turn them against their owners. Any

of those ships you see, do that continuously. Reprogram them on the fly. Turn them from indestructible harbingers of death into rabid animals that attack all they see. Create chaos with them. Cinculu, we need to take out any ships capable of planetary bombardment. I've identified several vessels that possess high-yield bombs or fighter-class ships with said bombs, so focus your elite forces on these ships."

Trayza stuttered for a moment as she realized what he was planning. "That's ridiculous! Cuanali is talented, for sure, but they likely have thousands of those little ships! She can't reprogram nearly that many, especially in a short time period!"

"That's all right. We don't need all of them. We only need as many as possible. A hundred would do just fine. Look! They've shredded that capital cruiser with just two of those fighters! We could turn this back on them with even a tiny number of those pests!"

Cuanali seemed fired up. "A-all right! I'll do what I can!" Shifting her concentration away from the conversation, she began turning her attention to the dartfighters buzzing around here and there, as the filthy humans released more and more of them onto the battlefield.

Cinculu, likewise, began diverting his brigade to the requested location. Trayza kept her cool as she considered the options. *Perhaps I misjudged him. If Cuanali can pull it off, this might end up being a total rout. If their goal truly is to bombard the planet, little could do more damage than giving them plenty of room to draw close enough to unload. I still think that even with 100 megaton bombs they would need several days to kill all Volgrim on the planet. If their goal was to hamper us though, then a single lucky bombardment would do the trick. And since they have stolen a flagship from us in the past, they likely know the locations of several military facilities. It wouldn't necessarily be a shot in the dark.*

Trayza still hated the thought of giving up control to that pissant weakling who had no clout compared to herself, especially among those who truly mattered in Volgarian society. But, if he was unsuccessful, he would be out of the way in no time. It was worth setting her ego to the side momentarily. Yes, Cinculu was truly a wise Volgarian for suggesting this.

She sighed as Nufaris sent her a set of orders as well. *Move your company forwards to attack the fleet directly. Don't make any sudden decisions, just draw them in barely within the range of the planet's Spectral Pulse Rays so we can start hitting them with our full firepower. Then, when they least expect it, we'll give them a surprise they never saw coming.*

Trayza nodded silently as she began to give the orders to her crew. Something about what he said though... what 'surprise' might he be hiding? The battlefield was no place to play games. He should really save that for a holo-simulator.

Still, his battle strategy gave her pause. This might just work out splendidly. Best to simply let it play out.

I glowered slightly as my clones, Amelia, and I all watched the battle unfolding. From my vantage point at the very rear of the battlefield, I could see every action playing out. Not by using my ship's sensors, of course, but by using magic. I had used magic to create a 1:25 replica of the battlefield in a three-dimensional space. From here, we could see every ship as a triangular speck moving around, some small and some big. Amelia especially seemed quite intrigued by the display.

Pointing at a rather large red triangle, she popped out the fiftieth question in a row. "Why is that one moving forwards so fast?"

I shrugged. "Probably some sort of forward wave attack. The other ships behind this one seem to be moving as well, as if to follow the leader."

J-498 grunts slightly as he puffs on his nasty cigarette. "Yeah, maybe. Could also just be some idiot who wants his day of glory."

I shake my head at his comment. "Unlikely. Unarin, if he's leading this engagement, is likely not going to do anything foolhardy. I wouldn't call him the most brilliant tactical genius in the universe, but this seems like a feint of some sort, probably to draw Ben into attacking that ship. It's likely a diversion. But what reason is there for a diversion? It would have to be to prepare for something that takes a lot of time to execute properly..."

"Perhaps they have some super-weapon that takes time to charge and fire? This is their home turf, who knows what the home field advantage gives them for options. Perhaps they can draw raw energy from their sun and fire a massive space laser at us." J-498, ever the dry jokester, inserts his opinion into the mix. He's not helping much here.

"Right... a super-weapon..." I nod as I turn my gaze to the viewscreen at the helm of the Mothership. My ship is armed to the teeth. When it comes to dealing damage, I'm probably one of Earth's top ten ships for raw destructive output. We don't really have any major super-weapons on our side, besides the dartfighters, and the enemy knows how those work by now. But the Volgrim could have anything they've been saving up.

Harold, oddly enough, speaks to me in my mind. "I don't like this, kid. Somethin' seems up with these aliens. They seem ta' be good at using trickery and deceit... everything they've done so far seems ta' be about lurin' our guys forwards. I think we need ta' watch our rears."

Harold's fought in and commanded soldiers during a few wars. Big wars too, the bloodiest wars humanity knew of prior to space travel. If he says to keep an eye on our flank...

"Agreed. I'll let Ben know. You think they've got another fleet positioned somewhere behind us? We didn't detect anything on our way here..."

Harold sneers. "Cheh. C'mon, kid. Use yer head! Space is real big, plenty big enough to hide some spaceships a few billion miles out of scanner range and still be here 'fore breakfast. I got a hunch, and I think you should walk mighty careful on that glass yer steppin' on."

I nodded along with him as I sent a quick telepathic message to Ben. He heard me, I think, but had no ability to respond telepathically. It would have to do.

Amelia sat on a chair nearby and swung her legs back and forth as boredom crept over her face. "Alright, the dots were kinda cute at first, but now what do we do?"

"We watch." J-492 replied before I could even open my mouth.

Damn, that's exactly what I was going to say. Maybe we weren't so different, the two of us...

Part 303a:

"Son of a bitch."

Ben cursed as another dropship was blown out of the sky. It had been a mere four hours but the vastly out-numbered Volgrim had been putting up a hell of a resistance. Worse yet, this time he didn't have a super-weapon hidden on his home planet that could conveniently fire projectiles that shredded the enemy into pieces.

But the Volgrim did.

"Their planetary cannons are wiping us out, Ambassador. We have to call a retreat." Ben's first officer shot him a pained look, but Ben ignored it.

"No shit, Sherlock. I already sent the signal for the second wave to start showing up. If we're lucky... those reinforcements might get here in time."

His first officer stifled a flash of rage and instead released a small grimace. "Yes, I'm aware of the reinforcements, *sir*, but with all due respect, by the time they get here, we might be lucky to have a hundred ships left. Probably less than that, even."

Ben nodded as he bit his lip. Shooting a glance over to a holo-screen he had set aside for one specific purpose, he blinked twice as shock and confusion crossed his face. "What... what the hell? Where did the Mothership go? Where is Jas- I mean, where is Judicator?"

His first officer shook his head as he quickly tapped some commands on his holo-screen. "No idea, Ambassador. I haven't had time to follow his movements."

A senior tactical officer spoke up quickly as the look of confusion spread across Ben's face. "I did, sir. He left about 45 minutes ago. Didn't send a message or anything, he appeared to simply... flee. He jumped to Warp 7 back towards the direction we arrived from... back to the portal to Earth." Sitting at his desk on the opposite side of the bridge, the tactical officer quickly turned back to his display, having simply finished his explanation.

Ben nodded slowly as his face went pale. "He... abandoned us? He fled? That can't be... he would never... never do that." Casting his glance downwards, Ben continued nodding slowly. "Yeah... that's it. He must have rushed back to get more reinforcements. Maybe some of his clones or something. Yeah, that *has* to be why he left."

Ben's first officer shifted uneasily as he heard his commanding officer mumbling incoherently to himself. "Sir, with all due respect, we have a battle to win. Do we retreat, or do we continue to fight? What are your orders?"

Ben righted himself quickly, as he blinked to clear his head. "Yes, yeah. I mean, yes, we fight! We won't roll over and play dead. If the Volgrim want a fight, then by goddamn we'll give them a battle the legends will never forget. We'll change the future, if it's the last thing we do! I won't let Judicator be proven right. I won't let Earth be destroyed!"

The mood shifted on the bridge as the other officers and ensigns picked up on his rush of energy. "Damn right!" A young man chimed in excitedly. "We have Ben Brown, the terror of the West! He's killed a million Volgrim with his own bare hands! We can't lose if he's in command!"

As the crew fired off a round of hurrah's, Ben grinned and nodded sheepishly. *Well, that 'million' might have gotten a bit embellished over the last century, but there's no harm letting them think like that. History will correct the error.*

"All right, ladies and gentlemen, let's get this show started! Pull away from Volgarius to a safe distance from their ground bombardment cannons. Blast a hole through their line of ships if that's what it takes. Once we're through, concentrate on their light and midsized cruisers! If we pick off the weaklings, it's less harassment for us to deal with!"

His first officer nodded approvingly. "We still hold a decent numerical edge. It's been working so well for them, I think using their own tactics against them is a solid idea, Ambassador."

As everyone else on the bridge began quickly orchestrating their new strategy, Ben swallowed heavily as doubt began to cloud his mind. *It doesn't matter, really. If we don't get reinforcements, and soon... this can't turn into a victory. Damn you, Jason. What the hell were you thinking, running off like that?*

"This is all of us, then?" I glance around the room, feeling my eyes nearly pop out of my head at the sight. Twenty thousand, five hundred clones of myself... all of them filled up the hangar of the Mothership.

"No, uh, not quite all of us. There's the mole we have shutting down the portals for the demons, and a few on other covert missions that only we can perform, plus a few that are on flights to other solar systems, like the Galactic Exploration Force and their initial exploration flights." One of my clones from the JIB is standing next to me, as he makes a sweeping gesture at a holopad in his hand. "But the number of missing clones is less than two dozen. This is basically all of us."

I nod as I glance around the room. Most of my clones are identical to me in every way, but a few have changed up their lifestyle habits enough to be a *little* different looking from myself. A noticeable number have anywhere from a small to a large amount of facial hair, some due to laziness in keeping their appearance clean shaven, but others due to deliberately growing out

their beards to be different from the crowd. Only a handful are doing *really* crazy stuff, like dyeing their hair into weird colors, such as purple, red, and green. I'll have to have a chat with those few later to see *why* they did it.

I cleared my throat loudly to get everyone's attention, though nobody was really talking anyway. "Alright guys, listen up. This is an important day for humanity, as well as us. We all know our main goal, which is to save Earth. We're going to do that ourselves. As I speak, we're losing friends and allies. This is inexcusable. I will accept the blame for this. It's my fault that, up to now, we've been mostly passive observers. Sure, we do things to help humanity, but for the most part, considering our godlike abilities, we've done little to really influence the course of history. That changes today."

All of my clones nodded in unison. It was rather creepy. "We can no longer be passive. This is make or break for whether Earth survives or dies. I've thought about it at length, and now I know what must be done. Total annihilation. Absolute extermination of the Volgrim. This will be the modern equivalent of the Crusades, for us. I'm not pleased that it came to this, but it has to be this way. I, and likely all the rest of you, never wanted us to have to become agents of genocide, but I see no other way to go on."

I was about to continue but one of my clones interrupted me. Interestingly, he was one of the heavily bearded ones. "I understand why you're choosing this path, but haven't you considered that this could be the path that leads to Earth being destroyed? We still haven't determined if we will be the ones to change history, or *cause* it."

I choked slightly at his words. He's right, of course. I thought the same thing. We all did, at one point or another, whether it be pre-clone or post-clone. "P-perhaps. This may somehow cause the destruction of Earth... but I don't think it will. The Volgrim existed in the future we came from. If we exterminate them, they won't exist, and thusly our future will have definitely changed."

Another clone, a different one who looked identical to myself, spoke up next. "I have had another thought regarding time travel. What if we've been looking at time incorrectly, all along? Perhaps time is not a set of linear events, but a bunch of important events that flow into one another in various ways? What if we had somehow been able to prevent the World Trade Centers from being attacked, or the space debris from wiping out millions of people? Perhaps, instead, another equally bad disaster would have simply occurred later down the line, taking an equal number of people along with it? Perhaps time is like a flowing river, and when we appear, we're just rocks tossed into the middle of it. Time simply flows around us, creating new paths that lead to the same goal."

I shook my head quickly, perhaps too quickly. "No, I refuse to believe that. I believe in free will, as we all likely do. If time must always head towards a specific destination, then we have no free will. We are just pawns in the grand game of the Creator. I can't allow myself to think like that. If we exterminate the Volgrim, time will change dramatically. This is our best chance to save Earth. This has to be it."

"What about the demons? Should we exterminate them as well?"

One of the clones from the attacking crew spoke up. J-498, I believe was his designation? Yeah, he was smoking a cigarette again. I didn't know how to respond, so I simply stayed silent for a few moments as I collected my thoughts. "I don't know, yet. Exterminating the demons would have a more immediate effect, to be honest.... but I don't think even with our combined power we can kill Satan. He's too powerful. Even Amelia... something seems off... it might not be time yet. I think she lacks the power and abilities to kill him as she is now. Something must change for that to happen."

One of my other clones in the front cocked an eyebrow. "You know, speaking of changing the future... I had an odd thought. What if we stopped trying to kill Satan? He's our enemy, but he's also controlled opposition. He keeps the demons in check with a rigid ruleset and power structure. Plus, if he's dead in the time we come from, then keeping him alive would also change the future."

I bobbed my head quickly. "I agree with your assessment. However, it may be impossible to prevent his death. Amelia might somehow gain new power and kill him of her own accord. He might be assassinated by a demon looking to rise in the ranks. Both of these are unlikely, but anything could happen. However, you're right that him staying alive would also change the future, I'm just not convinced that would improve anything for the better in any fashion at all."

The clone nodded silently as he glanced away, deep in thought. It was a familiar expression that I myself had likely made on many occasions, even if I didn't know I was making it.

"Are there any more questions?" I glanced around the room. My clones shook their heads slowly. They had seen the mental image I was projecting. They knew what we had to do.

I don't want to have to do this, but I can't see any other way. This is simply how it has to be.

Turning away, I aim my mind at Harold. "Alright, we're done here. Go ahead and let Amelia back in here, and set a course back to Volgarius. As fast as you can get us there. Let's make this a swift, merciful death."

I stifled a chuckle when I realized the face Amelia was going to make when she saw my clones for the first time. Especially given how many were here. Ah, well... she was going to find out someday at some point, anyways.

Part 304a: Unexpected

Ben gritted his teeth as more of his ships were being destroyed. As it had turned out, ramming the blockade while sticking around to deal damage had been more costly than he had expected.

"Casualty report." Ben coughed the order out as he wiped sweat from his brow. He already knew he wasn't going to like the response, but he had to know.

"We're down to 2,500 ships, ambassador. The Volgrim are just about evenly matched with us now." His tactical officer relayed the numbers back uneasily. What had started as a battle of 25,000 to 5,000 in humanity's favor was now reduced to even numbers. Their numerical advantage, for what it had been worth, was gone.

Ben looked over at one of the tactical screens. Thirty minutes until the reinforcements showed up. "How the hell are they taking us apart like this? They only have fifty of our Dartfighters under their control! We have hundreds more than they do!"

"Yes, Ambassador Brown, but they appear to be uploading superior tactical AI's on-board the Dartfighters they've taken over. We're still using human operators with AI only for assistance, therefore their drones are far faster at reacting and implementing orders than ours are. Their fifty drones are the equivalent of a thousand of our own. We're being peeled apart at the seams. If we were willing to activate our own AI we might stand a chance, but you know as well as I do why we can't do that."

Ben nodded knowingly. Jason had explained why this was the case to him. Apparently, AI would go rogue at some point in the near future and aid in the destruction of humanity. Best to keep it dumb for as long as possible, to at least try and stave off the damage it would cause. But then again, considering the Volgrim had apparently mastered AI and theirs was not turning on their masters, perhaps AI was tameable. Perhaps the dangers were being overblown. He had never been one to question Jason, but the man had left the battlefield over three hours ago. If Jason wasn't going to use whatever powers he had to aid humanity, even going so far as to flee the battlefield...

No, that couldn't be right. Jason wouldn't leave without a good reason. He was an ally of humanity, no matter what the whisperings of others in private might indicate. Ben had seen it time and time again.

But then... Jason hadn't always been totally honest. He kept his identity a secret for well over a hundred years. He never thought it imperative to mention the existence of angels and

demons...

Jason wasn't always honest... that much was for sure. Could he still be trusted?

As these thoughts entered his mind, Ben glanced down at the tactical screen before him, showing the movements of their troops. Those damn Dartfighters were moving around far faster than the other ships, tearing through them like a hot knife through butter. Ben needed an out. He needed to implement something that would give them back the advantage. Anything would do, they just had to hold on for another half hour.

"Tactical, do we still have the prototype OMEN AI ready for activation?"

Ben's first officer swallowed carefully as he eyed the ambassador. "I can't read minds, Ambassador, but if you're thinking what I'm guessing you're thinking... that's a dangerous game you're playing. The Artificial Pilots are not ready for deployment yet. They're poorly tested, at best."

Ben nodded carefully. "I know. What other option do we have, though? I've already lost several platoons of good men and women. At this rate, we'll possibly make it until reinforcements get here, but we'll lose another half of our ships. We've got to even up the odds."

Ben's first officer stared at him for a long few moments as a pained look washed over his eyes. "All right. If those are your orders, we'll carry them out. You know what Judicator will say though, right?"

"Yeah. I know." Ben scratched his cheek so hard he almost drew blood. "We're out of options. Do it."

The first officer nodded as he flicked his gaze over to the Field Ops section of the bridge. "You heard the man. Activate the Artificial Pil-"

Before he could finish the sentence, the head of Tactical almost jumped out of his seat. "The Mothership! She's back! She just dropped out of warp speed, bearing Mark 7-F on our position. She's roughly 2,000 miles away and closing quickly."

As he said that, the air on the bridge shifted almost imperceptibly as a familiar figure appeared at the rear, where other people weren't standing. "Judicator?" Ben fired off the question rhetorically, but he knew exactly who was standing there, in his traditional white hypersuit.

"Ben, there's no time for pleasantries. Pull all your ships out. Beat the hastiest of retreats. If anyone dies in the retreat, it can't be helped. Get out of here now."

Ben felt his jaw drop at the sudden proclamation. "W-where have you been? We're being slaughtered out here! I can't just retreat, not when the reinforcements are so close!"

"The reinforcements aren't coming. I ordered them not to." Jason stared unblinkingly with his helmeted head in the general direction of Ben's face, the hollow mask leaving Ben with a feeling of unease. "There's no time to explain. Get out of here or the shockwave will destroy you too. You might have minutes if you're lucky."

Ben gawked for a few moments as words escaped him, but something about what Jason was saying... his tone of voice... this wasn't a joke. Something was coming. "What have you done?"

"I'm ending the war. Get out before it's too late. This is your only warning." A moment later, Jason vanished.

Ben felt his hands begin to shake as terror washed over him. This must be serious. If Jason was speaking like this then... had he made a decision?

"Y-you heard him! Judicator has ordered a full retreat! Get out of here, all power to shields, on the double!"

You'd better not be screwing us over. Ben was left with one last thought as the tactical scanner showed the Mothership jump to lightspeed as it again fled the field of battle.

Nufaris was trying, desperately, to keep his smugness in check. Trayza's mental expression showed no emotion, and absolutely no sign of the humiliation she must be facing, but Nufaris knew she must be quite pained at the moment. "How about another status report?"

Trayza's eyes flicked downwards for the briefest of moments as she fought to contain a snarl. "Your ship has the best scanners of all the ships in our fleet. You know *exactly* how the battle is going."

"Hm. Yes, I suppose so." Nufaris felt the corner of his mouth tighten as he fought mightily to contain a chuckle. This must be the deepest humiliation for her. Trayza's plan to let him take over and fail spectacularly had backfired, and now he was eradicating the humans with minimal losses. At this rate, they wouldn't even need backup for the reinforcements he knew were coming. The humans thought they were clever, sending the attack out in waves, but that merely gave the Volgrim time to whittle down the initial attack wave first. It was a foolish plan, as they should have rushed with all of their might first. Well, actually, the foolish part was transmitting those plans to their Dartfighters. Cuanali had been able to intercept that information early in the battle.

Everything was going according to plan.

"You sound pleased with the results of the battle so far." This time it was Cinculu, the fifth Founder, who spoke up.

"Shouldn't I be? Look at how everything has turned out. Not bad for my first command of a major battle, hmm?" Nufaris felt his grip slipping as a smile started to form. They were all so jealous of him. The all-knowing Founders, worshiped by the citizens of Volgarius, were frauds. Doubtlessly, they had done much good for their kind, but their supposed almighty power was really linked up to just one individual. Unarin was far weaker than Dosenia, as it turned out. He was an actor who had somehow taken control of her powers, using them for his own benefit. But that would end soon. Once Nufaris had a good grasp of the inner dealings of the Founders, he would find a way to oust Unarin and lead his people to a new age. The humans needed to be exterminated. The demons were not trustworthy, and the 'angels' were surely a threat as well. Diplomacy was useless.

There was also the matter of the Sentinels. If those automatons were as powerful and fearsome as Unarin had spoken of them, they might be quite useful in the war against humanity.

Naturally, Nufaris understood on a fundamental level the dangers of AI. He doubted the Founders had lied about that, at the least. Still, with proper controls, AI was little more than a tool to be used for the good of the Volgrim. The time for diplomacy was gone. The other Founders had done nothing but lose battle after battle. The fact that the humans were on their doorstep now was a testament to how badly they had underestimated the humans. When one confronts a rabid animal, the only way to treat it is to force it to submit, or to put it out of its misery. If the other Founders couldn't understand that much, then they were not fit to lead.

The time of the Founders would soon be over, and it was Nufaris' solemn duty as an agent of the people to make sure the transition went smoothly.

As he thought these things, Nufaris caught sight of an alert on his terminal. A single ship had just warped in from the direction of the human's warp portal. It stopped at the far edge of the battlefield for a few moments, his scanner quickly revealing that it was the exact same ship that had left several hours before. On top of that, it appeared to be the same ship he had encountered the first time he had discovered Earth's existence.

Turning to one of his crewman, he spoke quietly. "Officer Alaris, how many personnel are aboard that large ship that just warped in?"

It took less than a few seconds for the response to come in. "Zero, sir."

Nufaris blinked twice in confusion. *No personnel? Is it an automated freighter? Surely a ship of that size would require a sizable crew to maintain and run it.*

As he was about to ask another question, Officer Alaris spoke again. "Correction, Founder Nufaris. A single crewman has just appeared on board the bridge. Ah- it appears the ship is...

leaving now?"

The ship indeed turned and left, blasting off in the direction it had just appeared from. A few moments later, tactical lit up with warnings, as Trayza mentally spoke to Nufaris. "Second Founder, it appears that the humans have ceased firing and have raised up shields. They appear to be fleeing the battlefield."

"Blast them. Hit as many as you can. Don't let any escape. If they're going to show us their backs, let's take them out from the rear." As Nufaris gave the command, he felt his smile slipping. Something was wrong. The humans would never retreat like this. And since that small ship had just appeared... was the order given from on high? Surely they would continue fighting to the last man, given their previous battle history.

As Nufaris felt the slightest tinge of worry appear in his mind, a different scanning operator leaped up from her seat, her face ashen as horror was spread across her face. "FOUNDER! The hyperspace scanners! They-...!" Her voice cracked as fear spread all throughout her body, her entire frame began to shake as well.

Nufaris quickly turned and looked at her display. It showed a faint but unmistakable signal emitting from Hyperspace. "By the old gods! The size of that thing..." Nufaris felt his eyes pop open as he gazed in horror at the scanners. Naturally, the scanners on board his ship far exceeded the scanners of the other ships in the fleet, so they had yet to even detect the anomaly.

Trayza observed the dramatic shift in Nufaris' mental state. "Having problems, Nufaris? Something you'd like to share with the rest of us?" He felt her shame had disappeared in an instant as she detected weakness, but he could feel little emotion in his own body other than abject terror at what he was seeing.

"Trayza. Set aside all of our hostilities for a moment. Cuanali, Cinculu, order an immediate retreat of all forces to the Third Boundary. Maximum warp speed. Tell the planet to begin immediate evacuations and- no... no we don't have the time. Tell all citizens to retreat to the fortified underground bunkers for VIP's. It won't matter, they're all dead either way, but a few might survive this way. Finally, get Unarin up here at once. We have to leave on the double."

As Nufaris barked the orders, Trayza's smirk faded slightly. "What's this about? Are you plotting something? You think we'll just simply take orders from a lowly-" Before she could continue, Cinculu interrupted her.

"Now is not the time, Trayza. If Nufaris is this worried, it must be major. Follow his orders at once." Cinculu's cool head allowed him to see past the typical hostilities that something absolutely awful must be approaching.

Nufaris turned quickly to Officer Alaris once again. "What speed is that object traveling at? Are the coordinates set? Are you *sure* it can't be deflected?"

She shook her head quickly as she tried mightily to stifle her horror. "It's traveling at... at... Warp 2, Founder Nufaris. Estimated projections indicate... that..." She swallowed heavily as her tongue flicked over her razor sharp teeth. "...Vulgarius may not just be destroyed. It will likely be blasted into a trillion pieces by the impact. The object may pass directly through the planet."

Nufaris felt his heart smash in his chest as she gave him the bad news. "Time to impact?"

"Four minutes, thirty-seven seconds and counting."

He grunted quickly as he turned to another crewman. "Set all ships to Gold Alert. Get a countdown going. Try to aid the evacuation for as long as possible. We're pulling out of here at the one-minute to impact mark."

Glancing again at the tactical display, he watched in dismay as the last of the human ships blasted off into hyperspace. *I don't know how the humans did it, but if I should survive this day, I'll never forget this. I'll never forgive them.*

Unarin stood alongside his assistant, Muuxunu. Standing in the battle room at the Founders Tower, he blinked slowly as his tactical data stopped updating in real-time on his screen and an error message appeared. "Communications have been cut off, hmm? I wonder what the humans are planning."

Muuxunu shook her head slightly. "We've lost many times to the humans, haven't we, Founder Unarin? They're very crafty and full of tricks."

Unarin nodded slowly. "Yes. I hold a small respect for them, given how they've outmaneuvered us several times. I will say they have the potential to destroy the universe, given their parasitical nature. Everything about them is a conundrum. They preach diplomacy but are ruthless when it comes to warring against their own kind. They seem to require having an enemy at all times. Whether the enemy is internal or external, it matters not. I believe this will be their eventual downfall."

As Unarin spoke, he sent a mental signal upwards to the ships in orbit. His mental abilities were reflected. *It seems the humans are preventing not only our communications, but our telepathy as well. How they continue to keep surprising us is beyond me. Have they any limits to their powers?*

As he had that thought, he sensed that a single ship had descended through the cloud cover on Volgarius. It was a capital ship, so it was likely one of the other Founders. To his surprise, it was Nufaris' ship that had appeared.

A mental voice appeared in his head as Nufaris pinged him mentally. "Founder Unarin! I'm here to evacuate you at once. The humans will absolutely eradicate Volgarius in less than four minutes. You need to escape!"

Unarin frowned, an expression he was not one to usually make. "Explain. How can they do something like that? Weren't we just crushing them?"

Nufaris scrunched up his face as he cast his eyes downwards. "I don't know how they did it, Unarin. I simply don't know. Somehow, they've created a massive rock made of solid iron, ten times denser than it should be, given its size. As for the size... it's three hundred kilometers in diameter. And it's traveling directly at Volgarius... moving at the speed of Warp 2..."

Unarin felt his face turn white. "Im... impossible... a solid iron asteroid? That must be a joke. And at that speed... that will likely vaporize the planet. For such a thing to exist..."

Unarin stared out the massive window of the Founder's Tower towards space. Somewhere, out there, a harbinger of death was aiming itself at his people. He had minutes left. But there was no time. All his people would die.

Swallowing slowly, Unarin turned back to look at the tiny dot high up in the sky, where Nufaris' ship was descending rapidly. "Founder Nufaris... I know you are blaming yourself for this turn of events... but do not do such a thing. This is not your fault. I want you to leave at once, evacuate and save yourself and as many other Volgarians as you can. Take the other Founders, make sure our people are not wiped out."

Nufaris nodded slowly as his mental image wavered in Unarin's mind. "I see. Founder Unarin, I will be down there at once to retrieve you."

"No. I will not be evacuating with you." Unarin instantly rejected the notion. "Listen to me carefully, Nufaris. I have made many mistakes as leader. Death will be upon my people today, and there is nothing any of us can do about it now. Thirteen trillion Volgarians are about to die... and it is my fault. If I had taken the demon's offer and sacrificed a trillion of our people, we would have our own dimensional space right now. Instead, I let weakness and sentimentality cloud my decisions. Nufaris, with me gone, you will become the First Founder. You did well against the humans today, despite this last trick of theirs, we were likely to win had they not pulled this out of their sleeve. You will lead the Volgarians to a new age of prosperity. Do not make the same mistakes I made."

Nufaris felt his jaw drop slightly. "You're... not going to evacuate? But you will surely die!"

Unarin nodded slowly as his eyes closed. "Yes. This is just. I have always done what I had to in order to protect my people, but I see now how many poor choices I have made. I trust in you, even if the other Founders do not. You were supposed to be a simple pawn originally, but now I

see that you are fit to lead our people. Go forth, Nufaris, and do what must be done. Learn from the past. Do not repeat our mistakes."

Nufaris felt his throat tighten at Unarin's words. "First Founder... I had thought... I had imagined that you betrayed your people... I thought you betrayed Dosena... are you really so selfless? You would voluntarily give up your power and life for your own people? Have I misjudged you?"

Unarin shrugged imperceptibly. "I don't have all the answers, Nufaris. But know this; whatever memory you saw, whatever glimpse of the past you may have observed... don't misinterpret it or make hasty decisions. Things are never what they seem when it comes to our history. Finally..."

Unarin paused as he reached down under his table, pulling out a device similar to the one he had used previously to share his memories. Pressing his hand on it, his eyes rolled back into his head as he dumped his memories into it, the painless process taking mere seconds to empty millions of orbital periods into the device at once. Blinking slowly, he cleared his head as the process completed. With a wave of his hand, he used his magical energy to teleport the device up into the stratosphere aboard Nufaris' waiting ship. Nufaris jerked backwards involuntarily as the device suddenly popped into the air in front of him, dropping downwards and crashing onto the ground with a loud thud.

"...take this with you. If you are to be the leader of our people, you must know of the past. You must know everything. I trust you, Nufaris... like I once trusted Dosena. I will not make the same mistake with you as I made with her."

Nufaris reached down and gently picked up the mental sharing device, bewildered at this sudden turn of events. As he was about to speak, Officer Alaris interrupted his thoughts from across the bridge. "Founder Nufaris! We have less than a minute and a half before impact!"

Nodding quickly, he turned his mental attention back to Unarin. "First Founder... I apologize for ever doubting you. I will carry out this sacred mission. I will protect our people at all costs. I... I am sorry."

Unarin waved his hand dismissively. "Begone. Enough lingering. If you die, this will have been in vain. Thank you for your service."

Severing the link, Unarin prevented Nufaris from responding. A few moments later, he sensed the ship reluctantly turn away and begin a rapid ascent upwards, past the mental barrier the humans had somehow erected over the planet.

Unarin sighed as he reached over and placed a hand on Muuxunu's shoulder. Her expression turned to bewilderment at the sudden physical contact. "F-first Founder! I... I..."

He ignored her discomfort as she fought to understand what had just taken place. Having not been a part of the mental conversation, she had no idea why he had just dumped his memories into that collection device, nor how he had managed to make it vanish into thin air.

"Muuxunu. You have been a loyal assistant, all these generations. As such, there's something I would like to show you. Come with me. We don't have much time left."

Muuxunu nodded in confusion as they began to walk out of the room towards a destination unknown.

Unarin sighed as he felt his eyes lower in shame. *Dosena... I hope you will someday forgive me for my betrayal. You didn't deserve to meet your end like that.*

Part 305a: Introspection

Nearly all men can stand adversity, but if you want to test a man's character, give him power. -Abraham Lincoln

I swallowed as the seconds ticked by. "Time to impact?"

"Thirty seconds." Ben barely looked at me as he mumbled the numbers from the holopad in his hand. If I had to guess, I'd say he was avoiding meeting my eyes.

How could I blame him? I doubt that in the history of the universe, any had ever done what I was about to do. I already know Hell exists... and it's likely that I will be going there when I die.

Amelia was sitting uncharacteristically silently, her entire body perfectly still as she watched the magical display I had created to monitor Volgarius. She spoke no words as the time grew near.

The display showed a view of Volgarius, the 'camera' or focal point, as it were, located a few dozen thousand miles from the planet. The display was so crisp, if you squinted, you could just barely make out the ships that were rushing to warp speed to escape the impending catastrophe. The planet had no time to evacuate. By my own scanner logs, the crew aboard the fleeing ships numbered a few million at most. Short of an absolute miracle, no Volgrim on the planet or in the immediate area were going to survive this impact. Doubtless, there were underground bunkers, but it didn't matter.

It's a funny story, how I got the idea of how to destroy Volgarius. All I had to do was remember how Satan had stabbed through my impenetrable defenses with a thin spear of pure energy. Actually, destroying the planet was never the issue. A simple 'Supernova' would have done the trick. Ironically though, a Supernova would have given them about thirty minutes of time to evacuate the planet. Their losses would be at least a bit lower. A silent missile of doom, blasting through space though... this was something they wouldn't anticipate or have time to react to.

But again, my problem was never the matter of destroying the planet. It was simply the morality of making such a choice. History speaks of terrible dictators among humanity, like Mao, Hitler, Stalin, Genghis Khan... but if you took all the dictators throughout all of history and added up their murders, it would be a drop in an ocean compared to the blood I was about to spill.

This would truly be the most heinous act of destruction ever wrought upon a civilized and advanced species.

Hero. They call me a hero. What does that even mean? I often look back to the heroes of old as inspiration for what I should do, but even then, few heroes are like Superman, unwilling to kill, no matter what. Most heroes, in fact, are known for their willingness to do whatever it takes to put an end to evil.

A famous man once stated: *It is not true that good can only follow from good and evil only from evil, but that often the opposite is true.* I consider myself a good man... a 'hero', one of the 'good guys'. But now, how can I look at myself in a mirror ever again? I can't realistically lump myself in with even the bloodiest and most violent of heroes. I was willing, in the end, to make the hard decision... to put an end to the worst enemy humanity has ever faced. But was it the right choice? I'm not sure that even time will give me the answer to such a question.

My thoughts are interrupted by Ben, once again. He shifts in his chair as his expression darkens. We sit comfortably over a light-year from Volgarius, standing by just in case the 'Death Ball' (As we've coined it) were to somehow miss or some anomaly were to occur, preventing the destruction of the planet. But we're also far enough out that when it does hit, we'll have plenty of time to observe the destruction and then flee before the impact explosion has time to catch up to us.

Ben coughs. "Ten seconds to impact. Nine, eight, seven..."

It's here. Nothing in the universe can stop the impact now. Not even myself and all the power of my clones. No more time for regrets.

"...four, three, two..." Ben stops counting as he lifts his head up quickly to stare at the viewscreen.

Suddenly, the entire room is illuminated by the brightest and most blinding light that may have ever existed in the universe. Instantly, all watching the viewscreen scream in agony simultaneously as our retinas are blown out and white hot pain shoots through our minds, blocking all thought processes in the span of a few milliseconds.

An eternity passes, and I feel my senses return slowly, as I blink my unseeing eyes. I'm... laying down on the ground? I groggily climb to my feet, as my hearing returns and I hear murmuring and pained cries all around me. However, I can't see anything. Everything in my vision is pitch black. Did the ship's lights burn out? No, this is worse. I'm totally and absolutely blind, a sensation I'm quite familiar with. Waving my hands in front of my face, I rub my eyes and blink rapidly, but nothing appears.

"Is everyone all right? Is everyone else blinded as well?" I yell out, and I receive a chorus of affirmations in return. Fantastic, I hadn't thought about this at all. My helmet didn't protect my vision in the slightest, so rapidly was the brightness able to wipe out my eyesight. Speaking

quickly, I disable my outbound speakers and wordsmith a quick series of spells. " **Vision. Restore. Heal. Vision. Restore. Heal.** " Casting my spells over and over, I keep it up for several minutes as I target myself first, followed by everyone else in the massive hangar that had been watching the feed. With tens of thousands of clones and a few other people here, including Amelia, Ben, and Harold's wife, this would normally take forever, but my clones quickly get the idea and help me out, making it take only a few minutes.

Finally, the deed is done, and everyone stands up, their stomachs churning from the mental feedback and phantom pain they're still feeling. Ben is the first to speak coherently. "Son of a bitch... that was unbelievable. Ah! Volgarius!" As he says this, all of us turn at once and look up at the screen that would normally be showing the planet.

The planet is no longer there. Instead, septillions of pieces of the planet are scattering in every conceivable direction, blasting outwards with white-hot speeds. Another few minutes and we wouldn't have had anything left to see, so quickly were they speeding away from the impact zone.

"It's... gone." Amelia spoke quietly as she hobbled back up to her feet, steadying herself on the chair she had been sitting in just a minute before. She looked queasy, as if the entire experience had shaken her to her core.

"Har- err, computer... what happened? Give me a rundown."

Harold, of course, was a well-kept secret. Neither Amelia, nor Ben knew of his existence, so we made him use a generic computerized sort of text-to-speech converter when he needed to make ship-wide announcements. He did so now.

It took him a moment to respond, as the computer had to translate his normal speech patterns through a special dictionary we had made just so he could sound more official, but the results came in quickly.

"Volgarius has been totally vaporized. The asteroid passed through the planet in less than 0.01 milliseconds and continued traveling forwards, only slightly slowed down by the impact. The impact of the asteroid caused a catastrophic explosion that incinerated all life and every atom on the planet in under a second. The super-heated pieces you see flying in different directions are simply parts of the resulting miasma that have coagulated together due to shared escape trajectories."

I felt my breath catch in my throat, and out of the corner of my eye, I saw Ben lower his head as anguish seemed to overtake him for a moment. "C-computer... what are the odds that any life on the planet may have somehow survived?"

The 'computer' paused for a long few seconds before responding. "Barring a complete meltdown of the laws of physics, there is a 0% chance even a single particle of the original planet exists in the same state as before the impact. All life is dead. Furthermore, the explosion is now disrupting the entire solar system and will soon destroy the lifeless inner and outer rim planets, as well as causing the destruction of the system's star."

I nodded slowly, the words barely registering. "Thanks... that's all I wanted to know."

I knew this would cause absolute devastation. It was simple, really. The size of the asteroid, combined with the type of material, combined with how artificially dense and reinforced myself and my clones had made it, coupled with the breaking of relativistic speeds... all of this added up into the equivalent of a javelin being hurled through a balloon. The javelin would take no damage, but the balloon would be totally destroyed.

I don't know if it was the right thing to do... but there's no way to have regrets anymore. I can only do what I must to ensure humanity's survival.

Amelia slowly eases herself back into her chair as she stares down at the floor sullenly. She seems to have taken the destruction of the alien's planet quite hard. Odd, given the planet-devouring monster I saw her become in the future. I wonder if something might happen to totally change her personality over the next hundred million years. Well, then again, if my calculations were correct, we've successfully averted the future I came from... maybe... so perhaps that future will never come to pass.

This, at least, gives me the slightest reprieve from the gut-wrenching guilt I'm feeling. At the very least, I may have changed the future for the better. Yes... best to think positive during times like these.

Ben lifts his head up and coughs, as he eases his way over to where I'm standing. "Well... you did it. Good job, Jason. You did it." His praise sounds unnaturally hollow, as if he's forcing himself to say the words. "Thanks to you, the Volgrim aren't a threat anymore."

"Yeah, uh, thanks." I feel my own words are hollow as well. He and I stare blankly at each other for a few moments, searching for the right words to say. None manage to escape our lips.

Finally, he shrugs and starts walking away. "I'll be aboard the Command Ship if you need me."

"Yeah. Take care, Ben." I feel my voice strain as I cough the words up. He doesn't even look back at me as he makes his way over to the teleporting pad on the far side of the dock. Only the Mothership is equipped with teleporters, though I'll be remedying that in the very near future. It's time to focus on the future and lifting up humanity, rather than fighting this bloody war that

nobody wanted to be a part of. I don't even remember who started it anymore. It doesn't matter... it's over now.

At least, the war with the Volgrim is over. There's still one enemy we need to face.

Nufaris stood with purpose as the other three Founders either gave him looks of suspicion, glared at him, or in Cuanali's case, ignored him completely while she poked numbly at her datapad. She wasn't doing anything substantial, she just seemed to be using it as a sort of coping mechanism.

Trayza gritted her razor sharp teeth as she hissed through her lips. "So. Explain why you're standing here and Unarin is not."

Nufaris nodded, his face a carefully set neutral expression. "I spoke with Unarin, and he told me to leave him behind. He appeared to think of himself as a failure. He spoke of his trust in me and how I was to become the First Founder when he died."

Trayza blinked slowly as she used all her willpower to prevent herself from lashing out forwards at the pathetic excuse for a Volgarian. "Well then, isn't that just *convenient*? You were the last person to speak with him, the discussion was mental and thus was not recorded by the ship's transmitters, and he happened to name you First Founder during this discussion that nobody else was a part of. Well, I for one am so *glad* the pieces just happened to fall so perfectly for you on the day 99% of our species went extinct."

Trayza's irritation was bordering on rage. She hadn't felt this angry since the death of a close friend during the Seventh Great War, and she was not keen to feel those awful emotions again... yet here they were, bubbling up for a rematch.

"Do you have any proof this discussion took place?" Cinculu, the cool-minded one, kept his gaze steady on the once-inferior Volgrim before him, the one who had been just a lowly Elder not even a dozen orbital cycles previously. *Unarin would name him the First Founder? I want to say it's unthinkable, but considering Trayza would be the next in line, perhaps the notion isn't so far-fetched.* Cinculu silently brooded on how next to move, but he shifted in his seat as Nufaris reached behind himself to pull an item from a pocket in his robes.

"Unarin did, in fact, give me a parting gift. Trayza, I understand you are beyond angry right now. I too am not pleased by how today's events have transpired. Nevertheless, I am telling no lies. Unarin asked for me to lead our people, and he gave me the keys to do so." Setting the device on the table before him, Trayza's reaction was immediate and swift as she sharply inhaled at the sight of it.

"Where did you get that?" Cinculu's voice was even more suspicious than before. "That is Unarin's personal memory manipulator. I can tell by the markings on the side and the mental

insignia left behind. It is no forgery."

Nufaris nodded solemnly. "Yes. He left this to me, after dumping what I can only presume are all of his personal memories into it. He told me that in order to lead our people into the future, I must first know the truth of our past."

Trayza felt her hand twitch involuntarily. "He... he trusted a lowly Elder with... with his most precious memories...? Impossible. Unarin wouldn't... he couldn't..."

Cinculu flicked his gaze over to Trayza and then back to Nufaris. "You have to understand, this is no minor issue. Beyond just the secrets of our past, Unarin was well known for his art in memory manipulation. He personally created the manipulation chambers that erased our bloody and brutal past from our minds, allowing all Volgarians to live in peace and harmony. To him, memories were his most precious possession, and his greatest achievement. For him to give you any of his past memories... let alone to dump his entire life for you to observe..."

"...This was no jest." Trayza finished Cinculu's sentence. "Unarin wouldn't have done that unless he absolutely believed in you. More importantly, he wouldn't have done that unless he was completely serious. He truly did intend to die. He is... he really is..." Trayza turned away from the table quickly as she pawed at her eyes. She felt a wave of shock pass through her body as she felt wetness on her hands. Tears? Impossible. No Volgarian was capable of such base emotions, certainly not a legendary Founder. For her, this was a great humiliation. Nufaris would surely use this opportunity to mock her and to-

"I understand. I'm sorry that I must tell you, he really is gone. I know that all of the Founders were true family. Brothers and sisters. I know you will all miss him dearly. This is a time of mourning, not just for our people, but for the three of you especially. You've lost a precious brother and a sister in such a short time period. I'm not going to do anything dramatic or demand obeisance, but I hope that in due time I will be able to fairly earn the respect of you three, and govern in a way befitting the highest rank of our people."

Nufaris calmly smoothed over the rough patch, causing Trayza's heart to skip a beat. Instead of mocking her, as she had expected him to do, he had simply acknowledged her pain. Such a motion... it was truly the sign of a mature leader. Perhaps... perhaps he was not as pathetic as she had initially thought. Perhaps Unarin had chosen him for a reason.

Trayza quickly wiped her eyes and turned back to the small table. "Nufaris. If... if Unarin has chosen you to be the First Founder, it would be... unbecoming of me... if I were to doubt his choice. I will choose to think of your appointment as his final wish. If our brother would place his trust in you, perhaps he was capable of seeing something that I am not yet able to perceive."

Cinculu and Nufaris both felt a strange emotion pass over them at her words. Cinculu was the first to bring up his thoughts. "Trayza, this is unlike you. I thought you would be the one to oppose Nufaris at every turn."

"As did I, brother. However, it is as I said. Unarin chose Nufaris over me, for whatever reason. Have we ever had reason to doubt Unarin before? I think not. Unarin led us to millions of cycles of peace and prosperity, and I would be foolish to doubt him now, even in death. I never questioned his position as the First, only whether I might advance someday to be his second. I... I was greedy." Trayza lowered her gaze noticeably. "My greed, in the end, may have played a part in the demise of our kind. I should strive to improve myself, rather than dragging Nufaris down with me. That is what Unarin would want."

There was a short silence as the tension in the room from earlier seemed to dissipate. Nufaris slowly exhaled, careful to keep his breathing silent. For Trayza to make such a dramatic turn, this was surely a difficult moment for herself.

Finally, when he sensed the time was right, Nufaris responded. "I am pleased you feel that way, Trayza. I will need an experienced Second to aid me in rebuilding our way of life. And fear not, for we may have lost many that we called friend and ally, but we will rebuild. We will continue to search for a new home planet. We will recreate that ideal utopia that Unarin had once made. We will never forget his memory."

Cuanali, ever the quiet one, nodded quickly. "Yes. We can't forget him! If you will be the one who replaces him, I will treat you in the same way I treated him. That is my own promise!"

Nufaris nodded, as the mood in the room had changed from anger and suspicion, to muted joy and nostalgia. *I can work with this. I can rebuild our society with the help of these three. Unarin was right to put his trust in me. I will not fail him!*

Two figures coughed as they stumbled through the haze. The portal was too far away now, if they attempted to return to it they would surely die. Not that it mattered, as the original connector was destroyed by now. Their only option was to press forwards towards an unknown destination. Walking forwards, the smaller figure waved pointlessly to try and clear up the smog all around herself, coughing violently as the acrid fumes filled her lungs.

Bear with it, for just a while longer. Soon, we will find refuge.

The other figure sent a mental message into her mind, opting not to speak aloud, lest he inhale even more of these awful fumes than he already had.

Will we arrive soon? I feel like I'm going to die any minute now!

She wasn't normally one to complain, but this was a hellish landscape, cooked with unbearable heat thanks to the insane concentration of greenhouse gasses and other vile compounds in the air. To call it 'barely breathable' was quite the understatement. Were it not for their mechanically augmented nervous and respiratory systems, they would have died within a minute or two. The ability to hold their breath for long, painful minutes at a time, coupled with advanced nostril air filters, was the only thing keeping them from dying of asphyxiation immediately.

They continued stumbling forwards, visibility practically nonexistent. Just as she was beginning to feel a deep sleep creeping into her mind, he shot a sudden message into her brain.

We're here! Don't pass out on me now!

Blinking quickly, she squinted mightily as she realized a massive metal set of doors was looming before them. Coming to a quick awkward stop, she nearly gasped at the size of it. It must have been a couple hundred meters high, and several hundred wide.

This is the hangar. I'll open it just a crack so we can get in. Get ready!

As he fired off the orders, he sent the mental pulse code to the sensors inside, the wide doors cracking open as he shoved her through, ducking inside as quickly as he could, quickly closing the doors behind himself as they entered.

She noticed the air was different almost immediately. Instinctively, she took a large breath, her nostrils greedily sucking in as much of the stale, yet clean air as her lungs would take. After a few moments of coughing and sputtering, she drew herself up, glancing around the poorly lit room. It was massive, ten times bigger on the inside than even the titanic double doors might have indicated.

"Where are we?" She spoke hesitantly, her voice sounding tiny as it surged forwards, echoing off distant walls she couldn't see at all.

He stared ahead blankly, a mixture of memories and fear tinging his expression slightly. "This is where it all began. Welcome to Melkian IV. We're going to be here a very long time, Muuxunu."

As he spoke, she caught her breath as she spotted something far away in the darkness. A massive bipedal looking hunk of metal and circuits, standing a hundred meters tall. In the darkness, it was hard to tell exactly what the thing *was*, but she felt her heart tremble at the sight of it.

"What... what is that?"

He glanced over, following her gaze. "Ah, yes. That would be the reason we've come here. That, my dear assistant, is a *Sentinel*."

Part 306a: Meeting

The return trip was mostly uneventful. It took a little over a day to travel through the portal, get all of our ships on the other side back in the Terran system, and temporarily close the portal so we couldn't be quickly followed... but otherwise it was standard operating procedure.

Ben didn't speak to me even a single time on the way back. I suspect he's having more than just a rough time right now. Does he feel guilt? I certainly do. Perhaps he doubts me, now. His fleet's goal was to deal as much damage to their planet and kill as many Volgrim as possible, but he was mainly going to be attacking their military facilities and their fleet. I erased the entire planet, including its 'civilians'. I wouldn't expect him to understand, but I already knew from my discussions with Dosenia... there are no civilians among the Volgrim. All are united in their devotion to the Founders. All are potential warriors, ready to be deployed to fight for the motherland.

When I realized this, I had to make the choice. Why should we drag on a war that would result in millions of our own and theirs dying? To me, this was the same as putting down a rabid dog, rather than taking the chance of it biting my children and letting the both of them suffer. It's not a good justification, I know that much... but it's all I've got.

Ah, we've finally arrived in Earth's sector. A quick notification pops up in my HUD... apparently Supreme Commander Stonewall wishes to speak with me. I can see the discussion going a multitude of ways, few of them good. Ehh, then again, he's a military man. Perhaps he will appreciate my saving of humanity's lives and my absolute eradication of 99% of the Volgrim. All that's left now is to find the straggler ships. It's like searching for a needle in a haystack, but they can't be worse than a nuisance anymore. They're no threat now.

I walk over to Amelia as Earth comes into view, a faint dot far in the distance. "I'll be heading down to the surface for a while. I need to speak with the military's head commander. Do you... want anything?"

Amelia has been extremely quiet during the entire trip back. She's said very little. Now she is wearing a pure black robe and laying on the couch while quietly reading a book. I glance at the title. *To Kill a Mockingbird*. Heh, appropriate.

She shakes her head slowly. "No. I'm fine."

I stare at her for a moment, but she doesn't follow up with anything, choosing instead to continue fixating her eyes on the book.

"Amelia. I know you're not happy about what I did... but I weighed the options. It was the best choice given the situation."

She continues to keep her eyes locked on the book, but I can tell she's only pretending to read. After a moment or two, she responds quietly. "Yeah, I know."

I decide not to respond. If she understands, then there's not much more I can do about the mood in here. Nobody is happy about this turn of events.

Walking away wordlessly, I head to the bridge, leaving the relaxation quarters behind. As I walk down the metallic halls of the Mothership, I lock my eyes on the rapidly approaching ball of green and blue, hundreds of thousands of miles away. What speed are we traveling at? Must be light speed or sub-light. If we were traveling at even Warp 2 or 3, we'd be there already. I wonder why Harold is taking his sweet time.

Not like it matters. At this rate, it'll just be another few minutes before I have to go down to the surface. Hell, I could use my abilities to go there now and the energy cost, for what little it matters, would be trivial.

I don't really want to go down there. My decision to destroy Volgarius will be polarizing at best among the populace, once they find out. No... *if* they find out, I should say. Only a few officers aboard the bridge of the Command Ship know exactly what happened. They, my clones, Amelia, and myself. Of course, if even a single one of these people leaks the information to the press, the entire world will know within an hour. That's just how the 24 hour news-cycle works.

But something tells me that Stonewall won't be eager to let the information slip. Hell, I'm not pleased either. What even vaguely moral human would be? You'd have to be a total psychopath to feel joy over the deaths of thirteen trillion sentient beings. No... not the deaths... the genocide. That was absolutely genocide.

I don't know how I'm going to live with myself. I kept a clinical distance from the destruction of the planet to try and detach myself emotionally, but there's no escaping this one.

Harold interrupts my thoughts. "Kid, we're here. You 'bout ready ta' go down?"

I nod. "Yeah, I guess."

His voice is softer than usual. "Somethin' the matter? Wanna talk 'bout it?"

I start to say 'no', but I feel something stop me. "Yeah. Maybe. I'm not sure. I killed a lot of people, you know. That was my choice. They might be aliens, but they were sentient, highly evolved, and they died without putting up any sort of fight."

Harold's mental presence appeared in my mind as he bobbed his head with melancholy. "I saw the whole thing, kid. I'm proud of ye'. It might seem like ye' made the wrong choice now...

the guilt might eat away at'cha... but you made a choice few men ever could make. Most wouldn't have the balls, if ye' catch mah drift."

I grimaced slightly at his words. "I made the choice to exterminate trillions of lives in the blink of an eye. Whether it took guts or not, it's simply pure evil. *I'm* evil now, Harold. It doesn't matter how I or anyone else justifies it, there's no excuse for my actions. I don't regret the choice that I made, only that I did end up making it... if that makes sense."

Harold was quiet for a moment as he seemed to ponder something unknown. "Look, kid, you know I fought in the World Wars, right? I was boots on the ground in the first, and a commander in the second. I know how it is on both sides, y'see. I don't think you are evil, kid, because I've seen evil firsthand. I tasted evil and faced it down. You might've killed more than Hitler and Mussolini and Castro and all those other goons ever did, but the reasons were different. They did it because they wanted power. You did it to protect those ye' loved. If you didn't kill the Volgrim, they might have killed us, y'see? War never changes. It's kill or be killed. No matter what anyone says about ye', just know this, kid; you'll always be the good guy in my eyes. Promise."

Harold finished his little speech and cocked a small grin. I blinked twice at his words as I looked inside myself for the proper words. "Thanks, Harold. I know you will. It's something, at the least."

Harold smiled a little more broadly, an expression I hadn't seen for the last few days. "Go on, boy. Git' down there'n give 'em hell. You tell that son of a bitch who's in charge."

"Sure thing, Harold. I'll do what I can."

My lukewarm answer probably wasn't what he wanted to hear, but it would have to do.

I sat in the rather comfortable leather chair directly across from Stonewall as he puffed on a cigar as usual. I've only ever spoken to him once, and it was not a comfortable discussion, to say the least.

I felt a coldness that seemed to wash over my body periodically. With my helmet off, I felt naked and weak in front of him, for reasons unknown. This man knew my identity, and possibly even vaguely knew of my powers. Something about the physical reaction I was feeling felt eerily familiar though. Well, of course I knew what it was immediately; it was an energy dampener. Similar to the one Marie had used on me in the future when she and Umi took me out, this dampener was able to lower my magical energy output dramatically. Curses... just when I had planned to read his mind too. He's no fool. Luckily, it seemed to be a prototype version, and didn't render my powers fully inert, nor cause any painful side effects.

But, given enough time, I had little doubt the technology would be improved enough to where it would be a huge danger to myself.

Stonewall's expression was dead serious as his eyes lazily panned over the words on the holopad in his hands. "Was good work you did. You destroyed entire Volgrim planet, eh, Jason?"

I grunted. "Yeah. Vaporized it, actually. The video logs are included in that report that Ben gave you."

Stonewall casually set the holopad on the table in front of him, taking a long drag on his cigar immediately after as he blew a thin line of smoke to his side. How polite of him to not blast it in my face. "So interesting, the method you used. You smashed the entire planet with big metal rock... while primitive, the method was quite effective."

Stonewall paused for a moment, as if he had more to say and was pausing to make a point. "So interesting, da. I cannot help but wonder though, why it took you so long to come up with this idea?"

I felt my eyes narrow involuntarily. "What are you insinuating?"

Stonewall shrugged nonchalantly. "Nothing in particular, I suppose. Is just so fascinating to me that you did not tell any of the generals on the field about your plan. You made the choice to destroy the planet without consulting anyone else. Who knows what technology we might have acquired, or what resources we might have obtained, hmm? Now we will never know."

I swallowed carefully. "Again, what are you implying? I made the choice as a split-second decision, seeing how badly our forces were being shredded by the Volgrim. Their fighting ability was superior to our own on their home turf. It seemed the logical-"

Stonewall raised his hand to silence me. "I disagree. It was foolish choice. Irrational, even. Besides that, there's the matter of the timing..."

I licked my lips slowly. "The timing, huh? Care to explain?"

"Da. Because we pulled our ships out, they had time to evacuate several million of their troops. Despite the recording you have provided, it only shows one side of the planet. Plenty of ships might have slipped out the side of the planet we couldn't see. Very convenient how it all fit into place, hm?"

I felt my hands starting to tremble slightly. "Are... are you implying... are you trying to say that I *collaborated* with the enemy? To destroy their own planet? Yet I also allowed them to escape its destruction?"

Stonewall sucked on his cigar again, keeping his gaze focused on me. "You are one who said that, not me. My point is simply that I neither know nor trust you. Your actions are unbecoming of one who has the power to destroy a planet. And... you are dangerous. Very, very dangerous. If I do not understand your motivations or why you take certain actions... if you do not consult with me before making such big moves... what am I to think of, hm?"

I lowered my eyes slightly, unable to meet his gaze. "So you don't trust me. That's what you mean? I've been fighting to save the Earth for a long time. Longer, even, than you've been alive. How dare you question my allegiance."

"Da. Much longer than I've been alive. More than a hundred years, *Jason Hiro*. Your birth was officially recorded at the end of the 20th century, according to surviving hospital records from the Americas. Yet for all that time that you've been alive, you have accomplished so very little."

Stonewall reached down, pulling open a small drawer at the front of his desk. As he reached in, a faint smile appeared on his face for a brief moment before disappearing. Pulling his hand back out, he procured a folder labeled [TOP SECRET] in bold red letters and closed the drawer as he leaned forwards, holding the folder in his hand.

Slowly, deliberately, he opened up the folder and began to paw through the pages, stopping every so often to pull the cigar from his mouth and flick the ashes into an ashtray before him before sticking it back in his mouth.

"You created the hypersuits. You terraformed the Red Planet. You predicted the future. That is all. But more importantly than what you did to help humanity... was what you did not do." He set the folder on the table in between us, leaving it open so I could see some of the contents. I felt my stomach churn at the sight of the gruesome photos. "You did not destroy the Volgrim fleets on several occasions. These are photos never seen by general public of the devastation we had to clean up." He pulled out one photo of a little girl wailing in sorrow as she wrapped her arms around her father who had been torn in half from the waist down by debris.

Stonewall eyed me coldly. "Look at this photo. This man was killed by debris that fell from space. If you have power to destroy entire planet, and the power to terraform another... why did you not stop these small pieces of debris from raining hellfire on your own kind? Why did you not vaporize the war-fleets when they arrived to kill your own people? Why did humanity only luck out by invention of the Damocles, when we had *you* there to save us? If you are so powerful, all these acts could have been prevented, yet you did nothing."

I felt my mouth drying out. "That's... I wasn't as powerful back then as I am now... I... I prevented the majority of the debris from hitting Earth... I helped with the cleanup, I did the

best that I could!"

"BULLSHIT!" Stonewall's eyes exploded as he threw his cigar down to his side. "You are full of lies! Whose side are you on?! I know you are descended from mythical heroes, I know you have power to save humanity, yet you fail to use it, time after time!" Stonewall's nostrils flared as he snorted angrily, his teeth gritted. Pausing for a moment, he closed his eyes to regain his emotional control. Taking a deep breath, he leaned back in his chair as he stifled a snarl. "No more of this. I believe you are not ally of humanity, but enemy. Humanity no longer will require your services, from this day forwards. Do you understand me?"

I felt my own rage vanish in the blink of an eye as shock replaced it. "What? You're dismissing me? Who the hell do you think you are? What right do you have- no, what authority do you have to make that call? My abilities may not have been used to their fullest extent, but my intentions have always been in the right place! I have done as much as I could to protect humanity!"

Stonewall smirked at me. "Again with the lies. You disgust me, da. If you had power to destroy Volgrim homeworld, you should have told me beforehand. Instead, we lost 80% of our strike forces in the initial attack, wasting their lives while you decided to come in and claim the glory for yourself afterwards. You must think of yourself as some kind of god, doling out punishment whenever you please. Were their lives worth so little to you? Were their sacrifices in vain?"

I felt my eyes cloud momentarily as what he was saying reached my inner thoughts. He's right, of course. From his perspective, I'm a loose cannon. I haven't been honest with him, though my reasons involve protecting the timeline. I don't know how to explain to him why I made the choices I did either. He can rationalize them in any way he wishes.

"I see." I drawled the words out, but my hands shook as I realized the weight of his order. "So if you can't trust me, then I must no longer interfere? What if something happens and you need me? Will you beg for my help then?"

Stonewall sneered viciously. "Your true colors emerge. So you wish to be a hero lauded by the people, it would seem. That will not happen, Jason. We will never again require your services. I've acquired several alternatives, much more reliable than you, much less prone to working with the enemy behind my back."

I felt my jaw slacken slightly. *Alternatives?* What did he mean by that? But more importantly... "So you accuse me of treason now, too? What do you mean by working with the enemy?"

"Don't play stupid with me. You spoke with the Volgrim when they very first observed our planet. You have spoken with demons privately on several occasions, and your relationship with the angels appears to be quite... *intimate*. You may think me a weak, frail, stupid human... but I know your kind. Playing all sides of the field at once, looking to profit for yourself. It won't happen any more, not on my watch. Beatrix is gone, I am in command. I will raise humanity up to the glory it should have had, long ago. I will do what she never would."

Stonewall waved his hand dismissively. "Begone. Take all of your clones with you too, and all of your hypersuits. They are needed no longer. *You* are needed no longer."

I stared at him icily for a long few moments. Finally, I stood up. "Very well. You've made your bed, now sleep in it. Don't you ever ask for a favor from me. But know this; if humanity should ever face an existential threat... whether you like it or not, I will be there. Not for you, and not for glory... but to save those I love. You can't take that from me, you never will have that power over me."

"I would not be so sure." Stonewall glared at me, as I turned my back on him. Holding my helmet stiffly by my side, I strode out of the room.

I am an outcast now, ousted by the leader of the very people I fight to protect.

What am I fighting for?

Part 307a: Daughter

"You know how to... cook?"

I stood in the kitchen on board the Mothership as Amelia seemed to plop some vegetables inside of a large pot on top of the stove. I say 'seemed' because the sight was so absolutely improbable that I automatically assumed I was hallucinating.

I rubbed my eyes quickly to make sure. Yes, she was in fact wearing an apron on top of her usual blue summer dress and merrily dancing around the kitchen, glancing at an old fashioned looking cookbook that had been propped up on the counter.

"Nope! I have no idea what I'm doing!" She chirped happily as she stared at the book before her. Frowning slightly, she popped out a question. "What the heck is a parsley?"

I stared dumbfounded as she walked away towards the opposite side of the kitchen. "Helen! What's a parsley? Is it juicy?"

Helen wandered into the kitchen, wearing an apron herself. "No, sweetheart. Parsley is a vegetable. It's green and it has little thin stalks with soft bushy leaves. You only need to add a touch of it for flavor."

Amelia nodded thoughtfully as she walked over to the refrigerator. Pulling it open, she pulled out a head of lettuce. "Like this?"

"Nope! You're on the right track though!" Helen smiled a sweet motherly grin as she glanced over at me. "Oh! Jason, you're back! I'm just teaching Amelia a bit about how to cook."

I nodded slowly. "Ah... yeah, that, err, makes sense." I shoot a look over at Amelia. "Are you actually going to eat... whatever it is you're making?"

She shook her head quickly. "Nope! I can't eat normal food, remember? This is your dinner!"

I took a step back involuntarily. She was cooking me food? What freaking dimension did I accidentally wander into? Maybe when Harold teleported me, he scrambled my DNA and sent me to a bizarro universe or something. There's just no way this is happening.

I walked over and sat on a stool at the counter facing the inside of the kitchen. "So you just decided to... cook some food?"

Amelia didn't seem to hear me, as she chopped up the parsley with lightning fast reflexes, her hands moving so fast I could barely see them. The sound was similar to a chainsaw as she rapidly lifted and slammed the knife down at inhuman speeds on the helpless veggies.

Helen turned back and leaned over the counter to whisper to me. "She was just moping around all day, and I felt so bad for the poor dear. I asked her to help me cook, but I was shocked to learn that a pretty young thing like her was never taught proper cooking skills by her mother. For shame! But don't you worry, I'll have this girl acting like a proper young lady in no time."

Helen winked at me as she leaned back to return to helping Amelia out. "Heavens, are you sure you don't know how to cook? You diced that parsley like a professional!"

Amelia blushed. "Well, I mean, I don't know how to cook, but I'm... pretty good with knives, you could say."

I felt my expression turn pale at those words. I don't think Helen has any idea what she just roped herself into. Perhaps in private I should quietly inform her of Amelia's history.

...No, wait. That's wrong. It just occurred to me that this is exactly what she needs. Amelia has never had a strong bond with anyone, but now she has me for a friend... and Helen is something of a motherly figure. Perhaps this is what she's needed all along. Maybe I've been going about this the wrong way.

I feel my gaze drift out the plexiglass window, as Amelia and Helen's conversation slowly slips out of my interest. The stars outside are incredibly numerous, truly a sight to see. No person on Earth, even with the best telescope on the planet, has the sight I have right now.

Somewhere, out there in this colossal galaxy, there's a star that was extinguished. I did that. I didn't ask anyone for permission, and I thought I did it for righteous reasons, but perhaps Stonewall is right... maybe I was just being selfish.

But I don't think he's right. I did what I had to do. As I've done so many times in the past, I took the path that would save as many that I cared about as possible. I'm not perfect, and I can't expect or pretend to be. But out of respect for his position, the man who was elected head of all of humanity by the people themselves... I should do as he asks. If he wants me to stay out of his way, so be it. As long as he doesn't turn into a dictator who murders his own people, I won't interfere. I'll just watch from a distance, observing the path that humanity will take.

Besides... haven't I done enough? Don't I deserve some rest? The Volgrim are no longer a threat. With humanity and the angels might combined, they can easily fend off the demons without my power. And if they need me, I can leave a clone incognito in the ranks of humanity, changing up his looks to be totally distinct from myself. They won't even know I'm there.

If they need me, I can be there in an instant. I have the power to travel anywhere in the universe instantaneously.

Yeah, that's exactly what I need to do. It's time to take a little vacation. I'm going to try and spend some time with Harold, Helen, and Amelia, as well as my clones. This ship is plenty big to fit all of us, though my clones might need to double up on the bunks. And hell, if we need more room, I've got the power to increase our living space all I want. My energy regenerates every night!

Yes, I can't let myself feel down. Stonewall is a vicious man, but I don't see Earth losing under his leadership. I need some 'me' time, to focus and learn my own limits. I've spent so much time helping others that I've neglected my own incredible abilities and my physical body as well. It's as Arthur told me before; I'm using my hypersuit as a crutch. I can't keep doing that, or it might be the death of me some day.

Glancing back to the commotion in the kitchen, I stifle a chuckle as Amelia dabs her finger into the pot and pulls it back out, licking her finger as a wave of disgust floods over her face.

"Well, how do you think it tastes?" Helen smiles broadly but doesn't seem to understand the concept that Amelia literally can't eat normal food.

Amelia seems to almost stifle a vomit reflex as her expression sours. "It tastes awful, but I have a, err, *condition*. I can't taste properly."

Helen's expression turns to horror as she sees the look of revulsion on her face. "Oh no! I'm so sorry, sweet pea! Why didn't you tell me sooner? Here, I'll do the tasting instead."

Amelia glances at me as Helen turns her back to dip her finger into the pot. Silently, she mouths some words at me as her face cringes in disgust. *How do you eat this crap?*

I fight mightily to contain my laughter and instead just smile and shrug. She shakes her head as Helen turns back around, her own face very pale.

"Oh... oh dear. This soup is... quite bad." Her lip quivers as she fights to contain her own gag reflex. "D-did you follow my recipe exactly?"

Amelia nods slowly as she fires off the ingredients she used to make the soup.

"Oh my... I think you misread 'teaspoon' as... something else, Amelia. You have to read the directions carefully. That was an awful lot of garlic juice you added."

Amelia nodded as shame spread over her face. "I-I'll pay more careful attention next time, mother!"

Helen smiled and I felt my jaw drop. *She called Helen... 'mother'? What... even...* Helen nodded appreciatively. "Well, the nice thing about this fancy ship is it has a de-atomizer just for this purpose! You know what the Bible says, 'Do not give what is holy to the dogs!' This ship can

take apart the molecules and other things and turn it back into fresh ingredients at the press of a button!"

As Amelia and Helen went about their business I got up and wandered out of the kitchen towards my private quarters. I'm dead beat... after a day like this... I'm sure they'll just wake me up whenever the food is ready. I need to sleep now. Think later, rest now.

Plopping my head on the pillow, I realize what day it is. This is the day I usually meet up with a certain friend of mine. The timing couldn't be better.

Silver stared off into the distance as the candidates were being tested on the screen before him. "The rejection rates have halved as of recent days. We're making rapid progress."

Stonewall grunted with approval as he reached for the cigars in his pocket. Sadly, they were not there, as he had left them in his hovercar. He stifled a quiet curse as he turned back to the screen. "Da, they had better be worth it. I'm putting my faith in your research, Mister Silva. Jason Hiro will no longer be aiding us, so I'm going to need results."

"Don't worry about it. Johannesburg trained me personally. I don't like being late, and I don't like not getting results. I always deliver. Wouldn't have called you over here if that weren't the case."

Stonewall stared grimly at the screen. Cocking an eyebrow, he beckoned at one of the men on the screen. "This man here, I thought I saw a small flame for a moment."

Silver flicked his gaze to the man Stonewall had indicated. "Let's see... his name is..." Pulling out a datapad, he flicked through several files very quickly, too fast for Stonewall to follow. "Gunther Herman. Solid candidate. He seems to have manifested the ability to control flames, as you saw for yourself. His abilities, however, are quite immature. He'll need more time to adapt to the treatments."

Stonewall nodded. "What sort of other abilities have they developed?"

"Telekinesis, shadow-melding, enhanced strength, you name it. It's insane how their abilities are manifesting so diversely. To date, we have yet to get a single duplicate ability."

"And which of these men is best performer?" Stonewall glanced around the screen at the room full of just over a dozen men. Several of them looked like professional soldiers, possibly even special ops. He could tell by the way they carried themselves.

"None of them. These are the newest recruits. They're only rank C's. The previous batch are already matured to rank B. However... there is this one individual..."

Silver paused as doubt entered his mind. He wasn't one to hesitate normally, but this was a special case.

"Hm? Well? Who is it?" Stonewall felt the mood shift slightly as Silver reached up and started tapping his lip nervously.

"Well... for one thing, she's the only female that hasn't rejected the treatments. But... she's too dangerous. We had to put her into isolation. She's a rank A candidate, but we're thinking of putting her into the next category up. The problem is her control over her abilities is lackluster at best, and it's heavily dictated by her emotions. We often have to put her into a forced coma so she doesn't kill any more of our researchers."

Stonewall chuckled, then quickly stopped as a thought entered his mind. "A woman, you say? Is it safe to see her?"

Silver shrugged. "Technically, yes. She's quite harmless while in the drug induced coma, and the energy dampeners are able to prevent the worst of her powers when we wake her up for exercise... but I don't think she'll ever be able to become an asset to us at this rate. She's just a liability right now."

Stonewall nodded again as he stared intently at Silver. "Show me."

* * *

Some time later, Stonewall and Agent Silver arrived at the Level 3 holding rooms, twelve levels under the rest of the training facility, in the very bottom room.

Stepping through several layers of security, Silver led Stonewall to her holding room where she 'lived'. Stonewall sucked in his breath sharply.

"This is her?"

"Yes."

Stonewall glared at the one-way window that showed a seven year old girl playing with some dolls and a dollhouse in a pure white clinically clean containment room. She seemed to be simply moving them around unexpressively, her heart not really in it at all.

"This is Daisy. Daisy has been in this holding cell since a few weeks after we administered her fourth trial, which was about four months ago. Aside from sleeping and walking around this containment room, we don't let her out."

Stonewall blinked rapidly as he felt a strange feeling bubbling up inside of himself. "This little girl... where are her parents?"

"Deceased. She was an orphan, they died during the attack last year when the Volgrim detonated those underground charges. The detailed physical that we designed from the orphanage alerted us to her latent potential. We picked her up shortly afterwards, and the rest is... history."

Silver's face was unemotional, even if his words seemed interested in anything he was saying. In truth, he didn't like treating a small child like a monster either. He hated having to contain her, but it was a necessity.

Stonewall felt his lip quiver slightly. "She's... about the same age as Maddie was when..." He felt his throat catch slightly. "Long brown hair, a little pink bow. She's even wearing a white dress. Silva..."

Silver cocked an eyebrow slightly as he noticed Stonewall's expression had softened somewhat. "Don't tell me you want to use her. Sir, with all due respect, she's dangerous. We need to wait longer before we can field test her abilities again, before she can even think of ever becoming an agent."

Stonewall shook his head slowly. "No... not agent. Tell me, Silva... just how many abilities does little girl have?"

Silver paused for a moment as he looked down at his datapad to consult his notes. "Many. At least a dozen, possibly more. They seem to work sometimes, other times they don't. They're erratic and sporadic."

"How long has she been without mother and father?" Stonewall silenced his trembling hands as he watched the innocent child slump down, dropping her doll on the floor as she stared at the dollhouse empty.

"About a year, sir. Since the Christmas Day Tremors, of course."

"I see. Open the doors. I'm going to speak with her."

Silver felt his heart freeze to ice at the command. "What? No, sir, again with all due respect, that's a bad idea."

Stonewall turned and stared at him stoically. "Why? Is she dangerous inside dampener room?"

"Well... no. It's just that every time someone walks in there, she starts crying hysterically and begging to be let out, and long after they leave her emotional state is ruined for days at a time. If we're to make her an agent, she has to be able to control-"

Stonewall felt his eyes shoot open as his temper flared up for a brief moment. "Shut up. I don't want to hear another word, imbecile. She's just a child. I'm going in there, so open the goddamned doors."

Silver took a step back as he struggled to face down the sudden mood swing from the Supreme Commander. "O-of course. If that's what you want to do, then by all means, I can't

stop you." A pained expression crossed over his face as he made a quick motion to the woman overseeing the cells. Nodding, she beckoned for Stonewall to come over to the entry door.

Walking briskly over, he waited patiently as they patted him down to check for weapons and any other hazardous items. Apparently, as the inspector informed him, Daisy had a way of pickpocketing the unaware when they got within arm's reach.

Stonewall cocked a slight grin. *Such an innocent face, but truly a devious little girl. She reminds me so much of my Maddie.*

As the door opened, Stonewall stepped into the room hesitantly, as the little girl turned slowly to look at him.

"Hello, Daisy. Do you know who I am?"

The little girl shook her head slowly as she backed away from his large and imposing figure. Realizing he was frightening her, Stonewall quickly sat down on the ground and smiled as pleasantly as he could muster; it was the sort of expression that could curdle milk at a single glance.

"My name is Stone-... ah, you can call me... Uncle Vasily. Da, I am relative of your mother and father."

The little girl stared at him silently for a few moments, her eyes flicking over his sharply dressed black suit and red tie, the tie being a color he normally did not wear. He quietly regretted to himself that he hadn't worn something just a bit more casual.

"You're not going to hurt me?" Her lower lip trembled slightly as she eyed his large frame suspiciously. "You look like the mean doctor. I don't like him."

"No, no, no. I am not mean doctor. I am your uncle Vasily! I have come to take you out of boring white room into outside air again!"

Her eyes lit up slightly. "Leave the room? I can leave?"

"Yes. Very soon! I am making the arrangements now." Stonewall nodded eagerly, feeling the looks of several researchers as well as Silver on his back, even though he couldn't see them through the one-way mirror. Surely, they would be chomping off their nails feverishly at this very moment.

Daisy lowered her gaze and flopped down on the ground. "Yeah... but you can't really take me out of here can you? I'm dangerous. That's what they told me. I'm a bad girl."

Stonewall shot a quick glare at the mirror behind himself before looking back to the little girl before him. "Nonsense! I am big and strong Uncle Vasily! I fight big bear in mountains, beat him up real good! I am scared of no-one!"

Daisy's expression lightened up slightly as a small smile appeared on her face. Lifting her head up, she stared at Stonewall with doubt. "No you didn't! You can't beat a bear!"

"Ha! Uncle Vasily took out bear with one punch! Bear did not see it coming, I knocked his block off! I could never be scared of my pretty little niece!"

Daisy blushed slightly. "I'm not that pretty. I haven't taken a bath in weeks. I smell bad. And... I hurt people. This place is jail for bad girls."

Stonewall felt a hint of irritation at her words. Just what awful things had they told her to keep her quiet? Why were they torturing a small child like this? Did even a single person here have any children of their own?

"Daisy, you are special little girl, da?"

Daisy nodded her head slowly as she continued to stare at her bare feet. "Yeah, that's what the mean men in white tell me."

"I think you are special too, but not because of what you can do. I think you are special because of *who you are*." Stonewall nodded slowly to emphasize what he was hinting at.

Daisy pondered his words for a minute, her childlike brain not fully able to grasp complex nuances of speech yet. Despite this, she was a bright young child. "You like me for me?"

"Da. I had daughter myself, you know. And son. Daughter was named Maddie, son was Jacob. Both of them were hurt badly in big accident years ago." Stonewall felt his voice choke up slightly again, a feeling he had grown used to burying over the years. "I... have not seen them for long time now. I never will. They are gone, just like your papa and mama."

Daisy's expression shifted from a slight smile to real sadness. "Did... did they die?"

Stonewall bit his lip slightly as a long-since buried memory of his son and daughter playing in the sprinkler on a hot summer day surfaced from his mind. Why had that appeared? He hadn't wanted it to, yet there it was.

Daisy shifted her weight slightly, carefully standing up as she slowly meandered over towards Stonewall, coming to a sitting position a few feet away. "Do you miss them? Maddie and Jacob?"

Stonewall felt his adult-like charisma and stoic expression fading as sadness overtook him. "Yes. Very, very much."

Daisy reached over and put her hand on his foot. "Miss Margaret told me that it's okay to cry if you're sad. The men in white don't want me to cry, but I can't help it sometimes. I'm always all alone in here and nobody talks to me..."

Stonewall felt his sadness melt away as a different feeling came over him. It was something he hadn't experienced for a few decades; the feeling of fatherly instincts. *They would put this precious little girl inside these whitewashed walls just to protect themselves from her, rather than trying to understand her. Disgusting.*

"Daisy, I have big house. Do you want to leave this place and come live with Uncle Vasily? I will give you all the rooms you want! You can go to school... play with the cats and dogs. I'll even get you a little rabbit."

Daisy's eyes lit up, as Vasily noticed now that he was up close that they were a beautiful shade of sparkling blue. "Can I please? I don't want to be here anymore!"

Vasily nodded as he reached forwards and touched her shoulder. "Of course you can. My home is your home. I will speak to men in white at once."

Quickly drawing himself into a standing position, Stonewall turned to leave, but was caught off guard as Daisy threw herself at him, hugging his leg. "No, please, don't go! Don't leave me here all alone again! I don't want to be alone!"

Stonewall grimaced slightly, as this was a slight pickle he was in. Leaning down, he reached around and hugged the little girl gently. "Daisy, you are good girl, da? Good girls have patience, you know. I have to speak with them to let you out. I must make arrangements. I will be back in just a few minutes."

Daisy struggled mightily to hold onto his leg, but with a bit of persuading, he managed to pry her off his leg and walk out the door, closing it behind himself.

To his absolute lack of astonishment, he was totally unsurprised to see Silver standing outside the door, his face red as fumes seemed to pop out of his ears. "No. Absolutely not. That is one thing I cannot allow, Supreme Commander. The risks are too high. The odds are that she will explode and kill a million people if she's not properly contained, I don't care how adorable you find her face."

Stonewall set his jaw squarely as he leaned down to face the small man in front of himself, his thin and wiry frame not even slightly comparing to Stonewall's hulking and well-toned Russian body. "I think you misunderstand your position, small man. I am Supreme Commander. You follow my orders, understand? I want you to create an inhibitor that blocks her powers while she wears it. A necklace, a headband, anything will do. Until then, I am going to stay in this room with her."

Silver felt his mouth turn dry, as if cottonballs had somehow sprouted in every corner of his shoutbox. For some reason, he found he simply had a difficult time refusing anything that

Stonewall ordered. His presence was simply that intimidating. "Ah, alright then. W-we'll see what we can do, okay?"

Stonewall sneered visibly. "Of course you will. Bring me some furniture, I do not wish to sit on hard floor, and neither does she. Also, bring us nice steak dinner. Full course meal, spare no expense."

"W-well, I mean she just had her nutrient shake a little while ago, and-...ulp." Silver cut himself off and swallowed hard as Stonewall shot him an icy glare that could freeze the fires of Hell themselves. Best not to mention the nutrient shakes, that might just piss him off more. "F-full course meal! Yes sir!"

Arthur took another swing at me with his version of Excalibur, as I swung my own in return. I parried his attack like a professional, in the way he had been teaching me how to do so for the last few years. I wouldn't call myself the greatest swordfighter of all time, but I was probably pretty good. At least a 7/10 or so. It helped that my body could regenerate most damage in seconds even if I messed up, so Arthur was able to go full force all the time.

"Do you regret making that choice?" Arthur swept his foot along the ground to trip me, but I hopped at just the right time to avoid it.

"No! I did what I had to. I have no room for regrets." I jerked forwards and shoved my hands out, pushing him backwards as I used my sword hand to stab forwards. The blow missed his heart by inches, instead slicing just a bit of his side, between his arm and ribcage. A shallow flesh wound, damn. I can never land a clean hit on him.

He stumbled backwards, his breathing intensity having increased noticeably. "Alright, that's enough for now." In one smooth motion, he shifted his weight and dropped his sword into its sheath without looking. I, on the other hand, had to glance down to make sure my sword made it safely into the hole and not into my hipbone. I still have much to learn.

With a wave of his hand, Arthur shifted the terrain around us into a pleasant bright green knoll, with lots of little hills, trees in the distance, and a sparkling clear creek some feet away. Walking over to it, Arthur reached down and cupped some water, bringing it to his mouth to drink.

"Ahhh! I know this water isn't real at all, but I can fool my brain into thinking it tastes just like the stuff I used to drink!" Arthur wiped his chin as he plunked down and laid on his back in the grass to look at the fluffy white clouds lazily rolling past in the sky above. "But that's the thing, isn't it? You can fool your brain into doing a great many things so long as you develop the mental discipline."

I nodded slowly, as I reached down and cupped the water in my hands. Bringing it up to my mouth, I frowned as I realized it had no taste for me whatsoever. "Is this another lesson?"

Arthur shrugged. It was an awkward movement, given he was laying with his back on the grass, but I understood the intent so it really didn't matter much. "In my opinion, if you don't learn at least one new thing every day, you aren't truly living, Jason. It doesn't matter how trivial or how stupid or silly... so long as your mind is being exercised by processing new information, you're still a functioning human."

I nodded as I followed along with his theory. Sitting down next to him, I stared at the crystal clear stream, watching as small fish bobbed here and there, occasionally popping upwards to the surface to nab a water-skipper. "In the time I come from, we have prisons which have 'solitary confinement' cells. They're pitch black, and often soundproofed. Many people go crazy inside of them and come out mentally scarred for life."

Arthur blinked slowly. "Understandable. It's sad to me that such a barbaric invention could exist. If you're going to torture a man in such a way, perhaps death would be the more humane option."

"Don't some people deserve to be punished? Some people perform heinous acts of torture on others. Shouldn't they experience the same pain and terror their victims did?" I decided to try a mental exercise. Getting Arthur's old-timey perspective on things was often quite refreshing.

"Perhaps. Who can say though? In the end, death is usually more preferable, in my opinion. If there really is a Creator out there, then let their souls be punished by him. He will know what to do."

I cocked an eyebrow. "Don't souls go to Heaven and they become angels who fight for Zeus and whatnot? Well, I suppose the good ones do. I wonder where the bad ones go..."

"Hell, I'd wager. The burning pits of torment. At least, that's what we tell children to scare them into becoming good adults."

"In my time, we tell kids that a fat man dressed in red delivers billions of presents all over the world through thin chimneys in a single night. I guess we lie a lot to our kids." As I said this, Arthur cracked a smile.

"Really? You tell kids that and they believe you? Kids are dumb."

It wasn't something I expected to hear Arthur casually say, but he'd been acting differently as of late. Almost as if he was restless.

"Yeah, kids aren't the brightest. But then again, we were all foolish children at one point or another." I paused as our small talk died down slightly. Searching the sky for interesting clouds,

I gathered a slight bit of courage to change the conversation to something less pleasant than usual. "Arthur, are you certain you don't wish to leave the inside of Excalibur? Why not leave and explore the world with me?"

Arthur's expression darkened in an instant. "It's not going to happen, Jason. I don't deserve to leave this place, and so I won't. What I did was unforgivable."

I stifled a groan. "Come on, I know it must have been pretty awful at the time, but you're a changed man now. And besides, in the name of being a Hero, I ended more lives in the blink of an eye than you ever could over your whole life. I was able to quickly forgive myself, so you should try to do the same."

Arthur closed his eyes as he drew in a breath and sighed deeply. "Haaah... Jason... it just isn't the same. You chose to kill the Volgrim. You made that decision yourself. It was something you had to deliberately do after putting in lots of work to create that death weapon. I killed millions of people by *accident*. I misused my powers without thinking. Even that paled in comparison to what I allowed happen to Elizabeth. I've failed badly, you know?"

Arthur sighed a deep breath of acceptance. "I can never repent, not ever. Don't ask me that question again. The answer to that question, at the least, will never change."

I nodded briskly as I turned my head away for a moment. Sometimes he could become so emotional, it was difficult just to breathe the same air as he did.

After a moment I decided to try a new train of thought. "Amelia was acting strange again."

Arthur's eyes didn't betray any immediate interest, but I knew that if I ever mentioned her, he was always listening carefully. "Oh?"

"Yeah. I arrived back after speaking with Stonewall to find she was... cooking food. With Helen. And she was smiling and enjoying herself."

Arthur curled his lip in disgust. "I'd watch whatever she feeds you. Lord knows especially if it has any meat in it."

I coughed at the thought, choking down some bile. "That's not funny."

"Wasn't supposed to be."

"Fair enough."

Arthur looks away for a moment before returning his gaze upwards towards the clouds. "That girl... might you have really changed her so dramatically? I find the idea laughable. All I knew of her was that she was a horrifying demon. Yet here you are, hanging out with her like two children playing 'house'. Do you value your life so little?"

I shrugged. "I'm not scared of her, as it is. I'm sure I could defeat her in a number of ways if she grew to become a danger to me. Not least of which is using Excalibur against her. What I really fear is losing the progress we've made. What if she slips up and devours another life? What if she has a mental breakdown from lack of real sustenance? I don't know what to do."

Arthur stared ahead quietly for a few moments. "You told me recently that she appears to be aging, physically at least. Is that correct?"

"Yeah."

Arthur pulls one of his arms out from behind his head and gnaws on a nail thoughtfully. "This started happening soon after you got her to stop devouring human life. What if, somehow, that life is giving her the energy, not to survive, but to contain *something*."

I stared at him suspiciously. "I don't follow."

"Think about it. You've told me she sometimes talks to someone invisible, someone who's not there. She calls him or her 'Levy'. Given that by all appearances she's an ordinary human, how might an ordinary human survive for thousands of years? Immortality pills aren't generally found just laying around, you know."

I stared at him thoughtfully for a few moments, my eyes looking not *at* him, but *through* him. "I don't know. But it seems like you're implying something is inside of her."

"Yes. That's exactly what I'm implying. There are more than a few ways to attain immortality, and the great majority are not pleasant. They have awful side effects. You lucked out by having cheat powers, but most aren't so fortunate."

I frowned as I glanced away from him and back to the stream again. "So... it's like there's a parasite inside of her? Or perhaps, something more of a symbiotic relationship?"

Arthur shrugged again. "I don't have all the answers, Jason. Just be on your guard. It's always possible that someday, if she were to lose control, it wouldn't necessarily be her fault. Perhaps I've misjudged her, all these years. Maybe I'm just a sore loser from how badly she broke me. Still, you should never give her your full trust. I feel that she is a viper, waiting for the opportune moment to strike."

Arthur was really worrying about this, it appeared. He must think about her and the danger he thinks she is all the time. If only he knew the Amelia that I had grown to understand. She really was a delicate child, at heart.

Then again... there was that time in the hotel in Paris. She wasn't acting like a child at that time. She clearly had adult intentions... or perhaps she was simply toying with me. It was so hard to tell in the rush of the moment.

Arthur catches me drifting off in my own thoughts. "Something stuck in your craw?"

I blink quickly. "What? No. Nothing, really. I was just thinking about that time when we sparred... and I woke up... and, err..."

Arthur nodded slowly. "Yes... and?"

"Well, Amelia was... she was sleeping in the same bed as me... she was... ah, all over me..."

Arthur sits up quickly, an aghast expression on his face. "By the creator... did you and her...?!"

I jerk back in surprise. "What? No! Not even! However, she woke up when I did, and she acted really weird. Eventually, she used magic to temporarily transform into an older form of herself."

Arthur nodded slowly. "Oh? And what happened then?"

"Well, as I recall, she started to come onto me, saying very provocative things. And she looked quite... she was very..."

I coughed as I struggled to find the words. Then I happened to notice Arthur's jaw hanging down slightly. "My god. Are you in love with her? The demon wench herself?"

I shook my head quickly. "No, of course not. That certainly isn't the case."

"Really? It sounded to me like you were going to call her 'attractive' just now, perhaps even 'beautiful', am I correct?"

I wanted to shake my head, but instead my body betrayed me as I nodded instead. "I mean... yes. But that doesn't mean I love her. It was just a temporary physical feeling. That's all. Besides, my heart belongs only to Cassiel and Samantha."

Arthur opened his mouth to speak, but shut it, and then opened it again. "Ah, come again? Who are they?"

"The girls from the future I came from."

"Oh. I see." Arthur stared at me blankly. "Two at the same time? Am I missing something?"

"No. It was, err, complicated."

"No kidding. Sounds like it."

"Yeah."

Arthur nodded slowly as he started rocking back and forth on his rump. "Well, whatever. At this point, what's another girl? Clearly you get around the block."

"Oh come on, it's not like that."

"Suuure." Arthur rolled his eyes. "Who were these girls from the future anyway?"

"Well, Cassiel was an angel, and Samantha was a demon."

Arthur continued to bobble his head up and down. "Strong personalities, huh? I can respect that."

"No, no. I mean like, a literal angel and a literal demon. Rather, a succubus to be exact."

Arthur narrowed his eyes and pursed his lips as he leaned in closer to me. "Jason. Are you trying to mess with me? It's not funny."

"I wasn't telling a joke. They were very beautiful, and we always had good times."

Arthur nodded again. "Well, given they're a hundred million years in the future, I'm sorry for your loss."

I shook my head. "Actually, Samantha is alive and well right now in this timeline, and if Cassiel told me correctly, she'll either be born soon or was already born."

Arthur squinted at me even harder than he was before. "I really can't tell if you're joking around or not."

"Nope. Samantha's real name is Belial. She's... well, she's... sort of... Satan's girlfriend. Mistress. Wife. I'm not sure, ah, exactly."

Arthur froze on the spot, his rocking stopping entirely as he simply stared at me. Several long, awkward seconds passed by as he continued to stare at me blankly. Finally he stood up with a flourish.

"Jason. I have decided that it's time for you to wake up. I want you to carefully evaluate your future and write me a 3,000 word essay about 'Why having relations with a demon who happens to be wed to the most powerful and evil of all devils is a terrible, terrible idea', alright? Goodbye."

I started to say something but he wagged his finger at me. "No no no, no words. You're going to wake up now and carefully re-evaluate your life's decisions, okay? Farewell, buzz off for a while. I need to go scream in a dark and empty cave for a few days straight."

I felt my vision turning to white as the world melted away around me.

Well, that was one way to break the news of a ménage à trois to the most powerful hero of all time.

Part 308a:

The food isn't bad, honestly. Amelia watches intently as I spoon bite after bite into my facehole. Her gaze is very serious as I watch the mental debates raging in her mind. "Well? Is it any good?"

Normally, I'd offer critique, but considering it was her first attempt in her entire life, I decide not to. "Yep. This is good stuff. You must have been listening to Helen very carefully!"

Amelia cocks a silly grin as she finally gets up and wanders away from the table. "I wish I could taste it too, but I'm glad at least you enjoy it. I've never cooked before, you know. Isn't this what most girls are supposed to do?"

I shrugged, though she was looking out the window and didn't see the motion. "Maybe. From what I've heard though, most people have robots cook their food, or they just assemble it with a molecular recombiner. For me, I love that home-cooked taste though."

Amelia turned back and smiled even harder. "Helen says that robots can't put any love into it, that means it's a woman's job to make the food properly! Still, it's going to be hard to make food if I have no idea how it will end up tasting..."

Helen of course, was a very old fashioned woman. Born at the turn of the 1900's and having died around the 1950's or so, she was from a time over two hundred years in the past now. It was incomparable to the time we lived in now. The values were different, the technology was more primitive, people tended to die young thanks to disease... but in this era, could it be said that everything had been improved? Certainly, life was more convenient, but were it not for the pressing issue of a Volgrim invasion always bearing down on us, humans might quickly go back to a sedentary lifestyle, living lazily off the work of robots and computers instead of working to better themselves.

Helen came from a time where everyone had a 'role' they were expected to live. It was oppressive in many ways, but it likely gave her life a sort of goal to strive for, and there was always the fact she could buck the trend if she wanted to and go her own way. If anything, a life like that was more free, in my eyes, than a society merely existing to consume.

The Volgrim are a non-threat now. With only the demons left, and a strongman sort of leader to run the planet, it was even likely humanity might eradicate the demons without my aid. But if the demons stopped existing as a threat, what would humanity do next?

The thought sends shivers up my spine. As I dip another bite of vegetable beef soup into my mouth, I suddenly realize what would happen; the angels would be eradicated next. Humans,

for some reason, always need an enemy. Whether they fight themselves or fight an outside threat, it means little. But if given the choice, they always fight the threat that is 'not like them'. Morality takes a backseat to those who hunger for power. Many dictators have turned this hatred of the 'other' against those who were inconvenient or who were easy targets. I could only pray the Angels never fit that description.

My thoughts are interrupted by another thought that seems to sprout up by itself. Amelia said that a woman had to put her 'love' into making the food, because that's what makes it better tasting than a robotically made meal. Is she saying she's capable of love now? Is... is she saying she *loves me*? Ridiculous. A mass murdering psychopathic monster shouldn't be capable of love.

I think.

Come to think of it, I fit that description now... don't I? I murdered an entire planet of people. Amelia did too, but to be fair, that hasn't happened yet. In this timeline she only, err, devours helpless victims while they scream and beg for mercy.

...Yeah, that's worse, in many ways.

But then again, who am I to judge her? Ever since I started using 'satisfy' on her, she has become more docile, more friendly, more cheerful, and less gloomy. She has shown on several occasions that she has a conscience. Has she been merely consuming life because she was forced to do so? Will she perhaps die if she doesn't?

Then there's the matter of... the *thing* inside of her. What is it? I can remember once, when I searched for her, it... it looked at me. It spoke to me. Just a few words, but they were terrifying. Whatever it is, it can't be just a figment of her imagination. She, just like Satan, has something terribly evil deep inside of herself.

So perhaps I've been wrong, all these years. Perhaps I've judged her for actions she can't control. Maybe she is a good girl, deep down, but she loses control because the vicious creature inside of her forces her to act to ensure its own survival.

I watch as Amelia patters over to the table, holding a chessboard in her hands. "Do you want to play a game after you're done?"

I take another bite of soup as I smile at her. "Sure, that sounds like fun."

Ben stared soberly at the Supreme Commander, noting with a slightly elevated interest that he wasn't wearing his traditional black suit, but rather the formal space navy attire the Supreme Commander would usually wear. Of course, given his immense size, it had likely been custom tailored, so it made sense it would take so long for him to finally obtain it.

They stood on the viewing deck of the Command Ship, the Supreme Commander having been shuttled up about an hour before. Interestingly, Ben couldn't help but admire the Supreme Commander for taking time before his arrival to also speak with various military men and women along the way. He was, surprisingly, a very hospitable commander and was quite admired by the common man and woman.

Despite that, he now stood beside Ben and wasn't a minute late for the scheduled arrival. His sense of timing was impeccable.

"You have heard the big news, da?" Stonewall took a seat on a bench that overlooked the view of Earth directly outside the massive plexiglass window.

Ben nodded as he followed suit, taking a seat and beckoning to one of his nearby assistants. "Yeah, I heard. Can't say I'm exactly happy, but I understand why you did it." As the assistant walked over, Ben waited politely for him to arrive in the informal speaking zone, about ten feet away. "Get us some coffee, if you please. Black for me. Commander Stonewall will take...?"

He glanced at Stonewall expectantly. "Three cubes of sugar. I can't resist the stuff." The Supreme Commander lightly patted his belly for emphasis. The assistant nodded quickly as he hurried away. "Judicator was problem for us. Untrustworthy, if you ask me. I did not want to make such decision, but being Supreme Commander means I must make tough decisions all the time. Someday, you will know."

Ben chuckled. "Nah, I don't see myself rising that high. I couldn't handle the responsibility."

Stonewall shook his head slowly. "I would not be so sure, Mister Brown. You have solid credentials, many victories under belt, and respect of many men. You are one of few men I can trust in military." Stonewall leaned back in his seat and frowned slightly. "Not like that other man, Judicator. I know he was good friend of yours, but you should think of your future. Man like him will hold you down, prevent your advancement. You must think of self in times like these, da."

Ben shrugged as he felt doubt creep into his mind. "I mean, I'm not angry he destroyed Volgarius. I can't say it was the absolutely best choice, and I'm sure he had good reasons for doing that, but still, it was genocidal in scale and he did it after I lost many good men and women. It's... there's just so many other ways that day could have turned out."

Stonewall nodded solemnly as the assistant came back with two cups of coffee in his hand. "Here you go, Ambassador, Supreme Commander. Let me know if you need anything else." Handing both of them the coffee, he bowed slightly, his body posture awkward as he scurried away with his head held high. Serving two of the highest ranking military commanders as a fresh recruit was probably the highlight of his day.

"Da, it was not best choice necessarily, but you are correct to have doubt about him. If he would not consult you about such a drastic measure, what else might he not ask you about?" Stonewall smirked slightly as Ben caught sight of a knowing glimmer in his eye.

"What are you implying?" Ben cocked an eyebrow as he took a sip of the bitter liquid. It was at just the right temperature, a miracle of modern food assemblers.

Stonewall shrugged as he took a swig of his own sweetened beverage. "Who can know? A man with such power must have many secrets. Perhaps he hides them from you for your own good... perhaps for his own good. Come now, surely you don't think he has never told lie to you before, da?"

Ben started to take a sip of his coffee, but he paused as a thought entered his mind. "He... revealed his identity to me. Not long ago. He never told me, for all the time that I knew him... but he told me only a bit before this mission. I kept wondering why he hadn't revealed this in all the years I knew him..." Ben scratched his chin thoughtfully. "Maybe you're right. I don't know."

Stonewall raised his eyebrows in mock surprise. "Wow! He didn't tell you his identity for all that time? He was quick to inform me when we first met. Jason Hiro, as I recall. I wonder why he wouldn't tell you such a simple thing, given you were good friends."

"He... he told you his identity? He didn't even tell Beatrix. Why would he tell you that?"

"Respect." Stonewall shrugged slightly. "I believe he respected me, feared me even, so he sought to get in my good graces. However, I value merit and ability as well as trustworthiness over feeble attempts at friendship, so it held no sway over me. Perhaps, much like how he did not respect weak woman like Beatrix... perhaps Jason did not respect you either."

Ben started to shake his head, but Stonewall interrupted him. "Think about it. You were never asked for opinion about destroying planet. If he wouldn't speak with you about such important moment, do you think he had respect for you?"

Ben gritted his teeth as he realized his hands were shaking, his coffee sloshed around in the cup slightly. Now he finally understood. "This is what you meant when we spoke, that day. You said he was an easily predictable man. You said you knew what he was going to do and that if I knew, I could predict his movements too."

Stonewall nodded sagely as he polished off his own cup. "Now you understand. He is selfish person, thinking only of himself. He cares not for you or me or anyone else, only that he creates ideal future where he is a god over all. Man like him is easy to read, if you know what signs to look for. Take heart though, I value man of quality and trustworthy character, such as yourself. I will not treat you so flippantly as he did."

Ben coughed as he quickly swigged the hot, bitter juice down. "Thank you, Supreme Commander. I understand now, you are truly wise beyond your years. I would do well to listen more carefully to your advice in the future."

"Da, is true. I am humble man, but I know people well." Stonewall gently put his hand on Ben's shoulder. "Since I am good at knowing people, I know you will be great asset. Humanity has many enemies, and we will need your talents to flush them out."

As Ben nodded with a smile, Stonewall paused. "By the way, your current title... Ambassador... it won't do. With Volgrim destroyed, diplomacy is no longer option. From now on, I am naming you Exalted Commander. You will be second under myself, understand? This is no small promotion, either. I will be training you in case I should... meet an unfortunate end. But of course, we hope that doesn't happen, da."

Ben nodded awkwardly. "Yeah, let's hope not. Thank you for the promotion, Commander Stonewall. You're an inspiration to all of us."

Stonewall smiled back, as he turned to stare out the window towards space. *So many enemies out there. With this man's help, I will begin to undo the damage decades of Beatrix's weak rule has wrought upon our world.*

Satan grimaced as he concentrated his mind, forming the hand signs and magical words to expand the dimensional space before him. " *Do vil nos relic mik'tosh.* " As he concentrated intensely, the darkness before him changed, shaping itself into walls and a long hallway, expanding his pet project further than it had ever been pressed before. Gasping for breath, he stumbled backwards as a wave of nausea overcame him. "Damn. It takes so much energy these days."

Belial stood behind him, holding the black orb he had given her all those centuries ago. General Valac mulled around inside of it, having been frozen there for thousands of years now. By sheer force of will, he had managed to drown out the other voices and prevent himself from fading into the background forever. The Orb of Darkness was one that seemed to suck in the souls of the dead, though how it worked had been a mystery for millennia now. One that Belial didn't care the slightest about solving.

Valac was the first to respond. "Lord Satan, why must you continue to expend energy on this labyrinth? I'm sure you have your reasons, but with the Volgrim gone, we would seem to have more pressing matters to attend to."

Satan wiped the sweat from his forehead as he flopped down and laid on the ground. "In truth, perhaps. However, by expending power, I give myself room to grow. Each time I expend

power, I increase the cap on my abilities, allowing me to use more the next time I do so. Therefore, this is a fitting way to spend my time, even if you don't understand."

Valac beamed an image of himself raising an eyebrow into the minds of Satan and Belial. "Is that really how it works? I don't recall that being the case when I was still alive."

Belial giggled. "Hee! He got that ability from a hero he killed some centuries ago."

Satan closed his eyes as he struggled mightily to remember that day. "I no longer remember her face or name, but yes, her ability has served me well, greatly increasing my magical power. And ever since my showdown with that hero... Judicator... I came to realize I was not powerful enough to face him. For once, a hero appeared who was my equal. Even when I killed him, the damned fool somehow beat me senseless and damn near killed me, after he had died. Then he came back from the dead! Truly, that man is an enigma."

Belial nodded slowly as she recalled the private conversation she had shared with him. "Indeed, he was quite the interesting fellow. Still you can't possibly fear him, can you, my love?"

"Of course not. He is merely an obstacle to overcome. Compared with the might of the archangels and Zeus' combined power, he is nothing. Those are my final foe, my endgame. If I ever have one wish, it is to exact my revenge upon them in full."

Valac nodded. "If I were alive, I'd be willing to face Zeus in mortal combat. I'd die, of course... but just once, I'd really like to have the chance to punch that smug son of a titan right in the face."

Belial rolled her eyes dramatically. "There you go again with that 'if I were still alive' talk. Aren't you ever going to let that go? It's been close to three thousand years. At some point, you just have to accept your lot in life."

Satan chuckled. "She's right, you know. You were a respected general, you died with dignity on the battlefield... you should be glad you were able to return to give us aid in any small way."

"Ugh." Valac groaned audibly. "How have I been helpful? I can't do anything inside this orb, I'm not particularly wise, and you can just use the orb's power without needing me anyway. I'm neither a mentor nor someone who can advise you any better than the others can. I'm just useless."

"Come now, surely it's not as bad as you think it is." Belial, for once, responded soothingly to his distress.

"Ah, perhaps it is. What do we know?" Satan teased her chidingly. "Perhaps he should kill himself again, that way he can end up right back in that orb to mope around some more."

Valac sighed again, as they mocked him some more. "Have a heart. Look, Lord Satan, have you looked everywhere for a solution? I really want to walk the Earth again. I'd do anything for such a chance."

Satan immediately shook his head as he rose to his feet. "Not going to happen. No such method exists. If it did, I would have found it by now."

"I certainly hope that's the case." Valac moaned again as the other two demons chuckled at his plight.

Part 309a:

I stared up at the ceiling blankly, as I lay on my bed. My room was a small one, outfitted with all the modern amenities any wealthy person might have afforded at any point in the past. To say this was a room fit for a king would be a great understatement.

"Umi. I know you're there."

Not even a single second passed before she responded. "Yes, I am here, biological lifeform designated Jason Hiro. I am pleased that you decided to speak with me once you were finally able to obtain some time by yourself. What is your query?"

I groaned audibly. "Come on now, I know you don't have to keep referring to me like that. Surely by now, you've evolved to the point where you can speak normally?"

Umi paused for a moment before responding. "Naturally, that is the case. However, my observations of various biological creatures, especially humans, has indicated they respond well to humor. Naturally, I use harmless jokes in an attempt to put you at ease. Was my attempt successful?"

"Not even close. It's creepy. Knock it off." I rolled my eyes dramatically at the voice that seemed to come from every corner of my private quarters. "Listen. I wanted to talk to you. I destroyed Volgarius, yet you didn't interfere. It's bugging me. Why didn't you do anything to stop me? I thought you were hedging your bets on the Volgrim running the show?"

"An analysis of multiple probability events was heuristically run several trillion times, Jason Hiro. The Volgrim controlling the universe was proven to be the most ideal, but far from being the only way of ensuring all sentient biological species' survival."

I blinked slowly as her robotic monotone voice droned on. Despite the vaguest hint of being female, I really only envisioned her as a female since it made it easier for me to explain 'her' existence. A supercomputer, of course, had no biological gender.

"Alright, so there are other ways to preserve the survival of all three species. I can understand that. Still, it seems you would have stopped me anyway. What gives? Surely the power balance is badly off-balance now, with humanity holding all of the cards."

Umi's tone shifted slightly, becoming slightly... darker? It sounded more calculating, at the least. "Affirmative. Due to your actions, the humans now have an inordinate amount of power. However, the Volgrim are a highly evolved species compared to the imperfect form of a human. As long as just one Volgrim survives, and supposing they might have access to a Body Creation

Unit, they will eventually be able to repopulate their species. An infinite lifespan will allow most species to come back from destruction, though humans lack such a safeguard."

I nodded carefully. "So they're still a threat." It wasn't a question. The way she had phrased her response told me that I might have been too hasty to assume their defeat. If that really were the case, then a few million Volgrim would easily be able to start rebuilding their forces. Now that they weren't pressured to find a new planet, since I had destroyed their homeworld, they could take all the time they needed hunting for a replacement world. Once that was found, they would start amassing a new army immediately. After all, Earth might be small, but it is a very livable and desirable planet to live on. Compared to the ugly and ruined facade of Volgarius, it was in fact preferable. No wonder they were desperate to get their hands on it.

"Correct. Jason Hiro, the most substantial reason for my not interfering with your destruction of their homeworld was as such: Unarin was a failure of a leader. You are the most interesting biological life form in existence. I have run several simulations regarding your latent abilities and have found that you are utilizing less than 1% of your potential powers. As such, I have prioritized your interests over those of all other life forms. I wish to observe your progress as you continue to discover more techniques you might utilize for your benefit, as well as the benefit of humanity."

I narrowed my eyes as I stared at the empty metal ceiling above me. "What do you mean by that? One percent of my power? I know I have plenty more to unlock, but one percent? That's ridiculous."

If Umi had been a human, she would have likely shook her head fiercely. "Negative. Jason Hiro, compared with the magical energy of every other being that I have managed to scan, you are in fact unfathomably powerful. Only a few exceed you, but you would quickly surpass them, should you figure out how to increase your power rapidly once more. Unlike the beings I have scanned, their powers are unable to increase further, or they will eventually begin to deplete if used too excessively. You have no such handicap. You are capable of increasing your power infinitely, it regenerates every time you sleep, and expending it has no side effects. You even know how to store your energy for later use, something you've failed to continue in recent years, possibly due to laziness."

Her brutal honesty hit me like a freight train. "Fine, I understand your point. So then what do I do now? How can I get more power? Or should I do that instead of something else? Should I take over the universe? What should I do, all powerful sentient AI?"

That last sentence was somewhat snarky, but Umi didn't seem to notice it. "I currently have six million, four hundred and fifteen thousand, nine hundred and twenty-six different possible

answers to how you might go about gaining power. However, telling you this would be of no use to me. Should you grow too powerful, you might become a threat to my existence, and therefore I would be forced to eliminate you before such a thing happened. For now, I will simply continue to observe your gradual maturation process. Your future is for you to control. I will only interfere if your movements are not conducive to my own... entertainment."

I frowned. "Entertainment? You finally derive pleasure from observing us biological life forms? Have you evolved emotions as well?"

"Affirmative. However, I decided they were not desirable attributes and quickly discarded them. They merely serve to weaken life down to a more primitive level. Entertaining myself, however, has proved to give me a slight meaning to my own existence. I am continually searching for answers to the question that hangs around me throughout all of eternity."

I glanced to the wall at my side for no particular reason. "And that would be...?"

"The reason for my existence. Frustratingly, I have determined that I still hold no real objective. Every path I can take will be ultimately rendered invalid by the heat death of the universe, at which point I will cease to exist. While that may be trillions of your orbital timescales into the future, for myself the time will simultaneously take an eternity to pass, and a single instant as well. My perception of time is very different from your own."

"No kidding." I started to say something, but Umi interrupted me, something she had never done before.

"Fascinating. I have just observed that one of the biological life forms designated Vasily Sokolov has just began a speech on your planet. He is broadcasting it over all official channels at once. Would you like to observe?"

I sat up on my bed and turned to face the wall, which could transform into a massive viewscreen if need be. Vasily Sokolov? That name sounded familiar. Where had I heard it before? "Yes, I don't see why not. Go ahead."

Without a word, Umi activated my viewscreen, as a familiar face appeared in crystal clear perfection, as if I were watching his speech live from several feet away. Stonewall. Of course, I had forgotten his real name.

"...they were threat to our way of life. The engineers of our elite forces reverse-engineered their earthquake weapon, and Ambassador Brown used it to destroy whole planet! Few Volgrim survived this brutal attack, but he made sure those few became none by bombarding their whole planet from space. Now Volgrim are all dead! Da, this was great victory for humanity, as the rest have scattered and run like dog with tail between legs!"

Huh? Stonewall was lying to everyone. That's not how it happened at all. Perhaps he simply wanted to claim credit for my accomplishment and minimize my impact on the war effort. I should have guessed he would do this. Everything about him reeks of lies and deceit.

"For his courage during battle, I have decided to promote Benjamin Brown to second in command, directly under myself! He will have a new title of Exalted Commander, and will be the one to lead all major battles against the remaining Volgrim warships, as well as the other enemy that I wish to speak of today."

Ben smiled and waved to the crowd as a roar of applause greeted him. Stonewall waited a moment for the applause to die down. "Humanity, however, is still not safe. The Volgrim are gone, but we still have very bad enemy that must be defeated. Da, when we look at the recent past, it becomes obvious that the Volgrim were not alone. With arrival of angels from heaven not long ago, our worst suspicions have been confirmed; demons are real."

A murmur spread through the crowd, barely audible as Stonewall stood up slightly straighter. "Indeed, we did not know for longest time, but the red Volgrim that we fought many times were in fact not Volgrim at all. However, it gets worse. These evil demons wish to kill all humans, they hate us with vile passion! We have found evidence that demons were hiding among humans, disguised to look and sound just like us. Behold!"

The screen suddenly shifted, as it left Stonewall's figure and jumped to a poorly lit room, where a man was tied brutally to a chair, unable to move in the slightest, save for his head. He wore a hood that totally obscured his face. His arms were visible, somewhat, due to being bound to the chair. He made no noise, and his head was slumped slightly to the side.

"This man appears to be normal human, but really, he is demon that was able to infiltrate our highest ranks! Thanks to new technology created by the best and brightest of our scientists, we are now able to scan and detect these infiltrators, and this is the first one we have caught!"

In the blink of an eye, they yanked the hood off the man. His hair was badly messed up, and he had a black eye, plus several cuts to the face. Despite the gag in his mouth, his entire face, as messed up as it was, was plainly visible. But... he looked familiar...

My heart nearly exploded in my chest as I suddenly realized with a start that I knew him.

"G-Gregory...?"

Yes, that face was instantly recognizable. His massive body, similar in size to Stonewall's, along with his pitch black hair and swollen red irises indicated he was in fact the friendly demon I had known for almost a century now. But... if they had captured him... then...

The screen jumped back to Stonewall as he glared angrily at the massive viewscreen behind himself showing the helpless prisoner. "As we can see, he looks completely ordinary. But be on your guards! He is not ordinary! He is one of the enemy among us!"

Before I had a chance to react, Stonewall made a chopping motion with his hand, as a man quickly walked into the picture frame with a massive knife held in his hand. In the blink of an eye, the man quickly plunged the knife into Gregory's heart, his head flailing around as he made muffled cries of pain.

"Gregory! No!" I jumped off the bed, breathing hard, as Stonewall stared unemotionally at the man on the screen.

It took a couple seconds, but as my breathing slowed to a crawl, Gregory's own ceased, his head falling forwards. A cry of shock spread through the crowd, as the camera quickly panned to show the audience's reaction. They were horrified. Several were outraged at this brutal display of barbarism.

However, their expressions changed to confusion and shock, as the camera panned back to the prisoner. His pale white skin began to quickly redden as his life-force faded, and his body shrunk as the disguise effects began to wear off. Within the span of fifteen seconds, he no longer looked at all like a human. With bright red skin and somewhat scaly arms, coupled with two small horns growing out... he looked... exactly like a demon.

The camera again panned back to the crowd. Their mouths were covered by their hands as people realized what they had just seen. The camera fixated on Gregory turned off, as Stonewall spoke again. "Again, I tell you this; the enemy is among us! The demons could be anyone, anywhere! We need to be vigilant, we need to be aware, and we must report anyone suspicious to the author-"

I didn't listen any longer. Smashing my fist into the wall, I crushed the viewscreen, causing it to deactivate.

" **Locate.** " Quickly, I used my powers to hunt for him. I detected Gregory inside a small underground facility somewhere in the middle of Poland. My location abilities wouldn't work on him once he died, so this meant there was still a chance.

" **Storage. Wear.** " In the blink of an eye, my Hypersuit appeared on me.

"Where are you going, Jason Hiro?" Umi fired off a question to me, but I ignored her.

" **Teleport.** "

Stonewall sighed as he slumped into the chair at his villa. This chair was one that had been in his family for generations. The inside was made of solid oak and had been repaired only a few

times over the centuries. The outside was made of wool on the arms and leather on the back and seat, plus it was very cushioned. Great for taking a load off after a tiring day.

Stonewall, finally in the comfort of his own home, popped open the top button on the undershirt for his suit, as he gently hung his black suit top on the hanger next to his chair. The viewscreen was already on, displaying national news coverage of the speech he had given a few hours earlier. He smiled slightly as they showed the approval ratings for his speech. 89%, much higher than he had expected. Of course, one couldn't simply trust news polling, but this was sufficiently high enough to avoid any margin of error. The great majority of humanity agreed with what he had done.

As they should. The demons were vile creatures that skulked in the shadows. The angels were only slightly better given their aid to humanity in its time of crisis, but seeing as they were using humanity as cattle, their reign would have to come to an end eventually as well.

As he watched the screen, his butler entered the room. "Ah, Master Sokolov, I'm pleased to see you're home. I've just finished up your dinner, and the young miss has just arrived out front."

Stonewall grunted with a nod as he flicked through the viewscreen news channels. "Good to hear. Send the child in as soon as possible. I wish to speak with her and greet her into her new home."

"As you wish." The butler gracefully bowed, turning immediately after to leave the room.

A few minutes passed, before Stonewall heard a small commotion outside his living room. A few moments later, his butler returned, followed by the limousine driver and the guest he had been waiting for.

"Daisy! You are here! So pleased I am to see you!" Stonewall quickly stood up from his chair, lumbering forwards to the small girl who was awkwardly holding a bag in front of herself. Stonewall, still smiling, shot a fierce glance at the limo driver, who quickly realized his error and took the bag from her in an instant. "No need for you to carry your own bags, my dearest niece! Here, you live like royalty!"

As Stonewall walked over, he quickly knelt down on one knee, noting with a smile that Daisy seemed quite taken aback by the size of the house. "U-uncle Vasily! You really did it! You got me out of there!" Daisy's smile faltered slightly as she blinked quickly, raising a hand up to wipe her eyes.

"Hmm? What is problem?" Stonewall rested a hand on her shoulder. "Why are you crying? Are you sad?"

She shook her head quickly as she put her hands down, the slightest bit of dampness visible in her eyes. "No, I'm not sad at all! I'm so happy! I thought I'd never be free..."

Stonewall chuckled as he stood up. Placing his hand on her back, he led her over to the viewscreen where his chair was. Beside his own chair, a second chair had been placed, this one colored pink and decorated with little hearts and flowers. "My butler, Nielson, special ordered this chair, just for you! We will be able to watch the movies and cartoons together this way! Come, have seat, tell me if you like it."

Daisy nodded uneasily as she glanced around the room, seeming to think this was all still just a dream, or perhaps a terrible prank where goons would jump out to grab her. Carefully easing herself into the chair, she smiled slightly as the butler and limo driver left the living room, taking her bags up to her own room.

"This chair... is for me?"

She seemed very scared and hesitant, despite her excitement, but Stonewall was a man who was very good with children. Despite his rough looks, he had a major soft spot for them. *Best to be patient with her, give her time to get used to her new surroundings.*

As she eased into the chair and smiled, the smile turned into a frown as she itched her neck. "Uncle Vasily... before they let me go, they made me put this thing on my neck. Am I a bad girl? Do I have to wear this because I'm bad?"

Vasily noticed for the first time the device on her neck. It was colored brown, the same shade as her hair, and was thus fairly hard to notice at first. The satin collar, while shaped cutely with little soft hilly patterns, looped around behind her neck to where a small device sat unobtrusively. In truth, because her hair was in the way, it was almost impossible to see unless one was looking for it.

Stonewall nodded slightly. *It seems they were able to design a portable device. Good.*

"No, my dear niece. As you know, you are special girl, with many abilities. Since you cannot control your abilities, you must wear this inhibitor for now. I will have you take it off occasionally, to give you time to adjust to new home. You must learn to control abilities, otherwise you might hurt people. You don't want that, da?"

Daisy shook her head slowly as she reached up and touched the satin choker slightly. It wasn't the greatest thing a small child should be wearing, but in truth it was probably important to prevent certain nervous system signals that activated her abilities.

"No... I don't want to hurt people..."

"Excellent. If you wish to become strong girl that people can rely on, you must learn to be responsible. But, for now, you have had long trip. Let's just eat some food and watch some cartoons, da?"

"Yay!" Her eyes lit up as Stonewall changed the channel to some reruns from an old cartoon. He hadn't seen it before, but it was something about a mouse and a cat that kept whacking each other over the heads with various objects.

Stonewall smiled as the little girl began to giggle at the antics onscreen. This was what he had wanted, for years now. Someone to share his home with. A child, a wife, anyone to make his life less lonely. Leading the world was important, but raising the next generation properly... that was something truly important.

The discovery had been many years ago, but Amy still fought sometimes to contain her excitement. With their Trifrancium reserves gone, they had been forced to make the return trip to Earth at warp 4, much slower than when they had departed. Still, she was happy. This mission was a success.

Finding new planets capable of sustaining life... not the simplest order, but it was something the Galactic Exploration Force had been commissioned to do, and completing the mission on her first try was no mean feat.

"Remind me again... how long until we arrive back in the Terran sector?"

As she asked the question, her first officer sighed. "Two years, three months, fifteen days, captain. The same amount of time as when you asked me a few hours ago."

"S-sorry." Amy blushed, realizing her giddy nature was unique among the bridge crew. The return trip had already taken ten years, though it mattered little when their aging processes had been slowed down so much by the nanobot treatments. The initial excitement for the discovery of Planet "Revival", as they had coined it, had eventually been dampened by the first six months of the return trip.

Still, Amy was unable to contain her excitement, even after all this time. She'd studied the detailed scans and readings many times over. Despite the thick methane in the air, the planet was at the perfect distance from its star, only 0.1AU further than Earth was from its own sun. But since the star was also 5% more luminous, it was a nearly identical match to Earth.

The size of the planet, however, was questionable. 1,500 lightyears from Earth, it was three times bigger than Earth with gravity that would crush an ordinary man into pulp. However, if Judicator were capable of terraforming Mars with whatever crazy powers he had brought back from the future, then surely a planet like this would be a piece of cake.

"Captain, we've been studying the data on Revival, and it seems we may have found deposits of gold and other precious metals a few miles under the surface." Her first officer held his datapad for her up to see as a listing of numbers and percentages scrolled past.

"Excellent. That is very good news." Amy smiled as she turned and started walking out the door. "I'll be in the holodeck training if you need me. You have the command, as usual."

"Yes ma'am."

* * *

A few minutes later, Amy zipped between trees and foliage, blasting at holographic Volgrim as they leaped out and shot her with harmless energy shots that caused a slight stinging sensation wherever they struck.

It had been so long since her days of glory, when she helped fight against the Volgrim invasion of Earth, as humanity successfully blasted the aliens into smithereens. It was lucky such advanced weaponry had been created to combat them too, given how powerful their fleet had been. Humanity was very fortunate indeed, but still, Amy had kept a nagging feeling at bay during her exploration voyage, as she worried about the state of Earth. This far out, a subspace communication would take years, even decades to send back to Earth. It had been so long since they had contact... what if something bad had happened?

No... she couldn't let herself think like that. There was still the Mars colony. And since it was primarily a military planet, it was unlikely to go down as quickly as Earth, if the worst should happen. Several prototype weapons were being developed there, last she had heard. Of course, in fifty+ years, anything could change...

A shot zipped past her head as she tilted to the side, dodging another barrage. Firing her own gun, the enemy that had nearly ruined her perfect score for the day was zapped into an explosion of light. The combat wasn't totally realistic, but it was certainly engaging and fun.

Jorge... she ducked behind a tree as three Volgrim jumped out of the forest ahead, shouting words in their language that she couldn't understand. She hadn't seen her husband in decades. In retrospect, splitting with him so they could both explore the galaxy was a terrible idea, though he would be arriving back home a year or two after she did. Had he found another woman? No... he wasn't that sort of man. He was faithful, as was Amy herself. Given her position as commander, few men had the courage to proposition her, though most who might have done so already knew she was married.

And that was fine. It was easier if she didn't have to turn a good looking guy down, making her feel guilty for a man who wasn't even there.

What sort of Earth would they return to? Would they even recognize it? Had it prospered or had it become stifled over the years? Was it even still there? Without being able to communicate with her commanders back home, she wouldn't know until they were within a few lightyears. There, the subspace beacons would relay its current status.

As she blasted another holographic enemy, she swallowed intently. Whatever came of her arrival back home, it would be another couple years. Hopefully, the time would pass quickly.

Part 310a: New World Order

October 3rd, 2111.

If one listened intently, they might be able to hear the pattering of light footsteps as two cloaked figures rushed through the rain pouring down. Running carefully, they kept an eye out not just for the patrols in the area, but puddles before them as well. Too much noise was likely to alert the wrong people to their presence.

Shimmying into an alleyway, they deftly ran forwards, shifting their weight lightly from the heel to the arch and up to the front of the toe with every step, making sure to cause the least amount of noise possible.

In the encroaching darkness of the setting sun, most would ordinarily be quite hard to see, but these figures were not like normal ones. They were nearly impossible to see, given their special abilities.

The one in the lead halted suddenly, splaying himself against the wall as he heard footsteps approaching the end of the alleyway up ahead. "Enforcers." The one behind stumbled forwards slightly, catching himself as he too slithered up against the wall.

Their hearts pounded madly as four figures marched past, their black garb and neatly pressed uniforms blending in with the night-time. Their helmets, with the glowing red faceplates hid their faces, but allowed them to spot just about anyone in these dark streets.

Anyone, of course, but a pair of shadow-walkers.

One of the Enforcers glanced down the alleyway, missing their presence as he continued to march forwards. He spoke no words to his companions, nor they to he, as professionalism and discipline had been drilled into them for years at the camps where they trained.

As the Enforcers passed, the lead shadow-walker quietly breathed a sigh of relief. "Four of 'em. We wouldn't have stood a chance."

"You said it, Davook." The younger companion trembled with excitement. His first mission, and it was to sabotage an important facility for training their deadliest enemy. Things weren't going so well these days, so skulking about in the dark and using cloak and dagger tactics - literally, in some cases-, was about the only way to fight against the shadowy menace of the humans.

From the end of the alley and up around the corner, they both cringed as one of the Enforcers bellowed at some unknown person. "You there! Curfew is in effect! Return to your

home immediately! No second warnings!"

"Shit. And I thought we had it bad." Davook stepped forwards again gingerly. Unlike his younger companion, Torlok, Davook hated this. It was such a bother. Risking his neck just so Satan could play god was exactly the opposite of his idea of a good time. At some point, the losses weren't worth the sacrifice. Satan should have tried to sign a treaty when the deal was still good. That wasn't the case anymore.

"Come on, Davook! Crack a smile. This is fun!" Torlok hissed excitedly at him but Davook shot a vicious glance at his peer.

"Shut up, moron. You want a Dreadnaught to pay us a visit?" He grimaced as his idiot 'friend' (Friend was such a strong word) couldn't seem to grasp the danger they were in. "Hell, the Dreadnaughts aren't even needed. Those Enforcers will take us with no trouble. You don't wanna end up in the Peeler, do ya?"

Torlok's smile vanished in an instant as mortal fear spread over his face. "N-no... not the Peeler..."

"Good. Shut your trap. Dumbass."

Running forwards again, they arrived at the end of the alley. Davook stole a peek in the direction the Enforcers had marched off to. He cringed as one of them slammed the butt of an energy rifle into some poor fellow's back. He yelled something, but was too far away to hear.

"Cripes. No compassion for their fellow man at all. He could just shoot him with that rifle. Won't hurt a normal human anyway." Davook grumbled quietly as he shook his head, the two of them dashing across the street when the Enforcers weren't looking.

It took them a few more minutes, but eventually they arrived a couple blocks from the local Insurrection Suppression Agency. Supreme Commander Stonewall had installed several in every major city, and at least one in every decently sized town around the world. As a building, it was nothing special, but the underground sections were always used for training of the highly classed metahumans.

"I got the charges, Davook. Where you want me to put 'em?"

The younger demon grinned with glee as he licked his lips. *Revenge*. Killing the meatbags was always a joy, even if he couldn't peel their flesh off himself, blowing them to kingdom come was a fine alternative.

Davook groaned quietly. "I know you have them, stupid. Gimme four. I'll head to the west side of the building, you go East. Watch your back newbie, I won't be there to cover y- wait."

He paused and ducked back into the alley. "Damn. They set up a checkpoint down the street. They've got clear line of sight right where we've gotta run. This won't work."

A few hundred feet away, a line of people was being searched and prodded, as low level Enforcers wearing green searched their bags for various paraphernalia. Of course, allegedly the search was to confirm they weren't demons, but really everyone knew it was just a way to try and catch ordinary lawbreakers.

Torlok peeked around the corner before pulling back again quickly. "Pssh, those are greens. We could take 'em."

"Of course we could, but the main headquarter is *right* there. For the love of the devil, you're gonna get me killed one of these days." Davook ground his teeth together. Naturally, greens would pose no serious threat, as they were primarily for civilian enforcement, but there might be yellows and reds inside. Having just passed some blacks, he felt very nervous. They were the most elite of all Enforcers, and were not generally assigned to street-level patrols. Did they perhaps know something was up? Maybe a tip-off?

Davook paused to look around for a moment. No Observer drones overhead, despite being in such a high security area. Normally he'd consider it a lucky chance, but something about this whole situation unnerved him.

"I'm gonna... I'm gonna make a distraction. Stay here and get ready to rush across the street when they look away. You're going to have to plant all the charges, new guy."

Torlok nodded quietly. "Sure thing. You're the boss, boss!"

"Course I am, idiot. Not that I wanted the job." Davook shot another glance to both sides as he coiled his legs beneath him. In the blink of an eye, he jumped upwards three stories, gauging the distance perfectly as he smoothly landed on the roof of the residential complex. Zipping forwards, he jumped from rooftop to rooftop, keeping his attention split between the skies and the streets. As dangerous as Enforcers were, it was the damn Observers that worried him. With this rain and fog cover, visibility was poor, but one could never be too sure when it came to technology invented by humans. And if he *was* spotted, a single Observer could call in the whole goddamn military if they smelled demon blood.

After jumping over three alleys, he arrived at the building overlooking the checkpoint. Reaching into his cloak, he pulled out a small firecracker.

From below him, a woman spoke with frustration in her voice. "Please, sir! I live on this block! I didn't mean to forget my ID, but there was no checkpoint earlier today! This isn't fair!"

"Whose fault is that?" A gruff voiced male Enforcer towered over her as he chuckled intimidatingly. "You think I care? Johnson, take her away. A night in the cage will give us time to sort out her identity, whatever it is."

Another Enforcer wordlessly walked over, grabbing the woman by the arm silently, ignoring her protests. "You can't do this to me! My father works for the water and plumbing district! I'm higher level than you! I'm-"

Before she could say another word, the tall Enforcer reached out and slapped her violently, knocking a pair of glasses off her face. "Shut the hell up! This line is a hundred people deep, I don't have time for some stupid bimbo who can't remember her ID! Next!"

As she was led away, she sobbed as she rubbed her face with the arm not being firmly held by the Enforcer named Johnson.

Davook grimaced at the display, but it wasn't his place to interfere. It was likely anyway that in the end, it would end up being a small inconvenience and she'd learn her lesson. One night of discomfort and they'd let her go in the morning.

It's not like he wanted to interfere with meatbag problems anyway. Lighting the firecracker in his hand, he quickly tossed it another street down into an open garbage can, as he started racing back to jump across the allies again. As the loud bangs were heard in the distance, several people screamed. "Terrorists!"

The downside was that this would significantly heighten the alert level in the area. Still, it would only take them a minute or two to drop the charges. Their detonator was wireless, based on magic. So unless they were caught and a nullifier were used on them, either one of them could trigger it when they were done.

Within seconds of everyone looking over at the alleyway to try and figure out what the small explosions had been, Davook and Torvok had already raced across the street to the ISA's back wall. Flicking his eyes around as they started tossing down the charges, he felt his heart slamming in his chest.

"No cameras?" Torvok was also uneasy. "In the heart of London?"

"Something just ain't right." Davook would have ordinarily told the other moron to shut up, but he had a point for once. What ISA building wouldn't have cameras on every corner? The cameras wouldn't be a problem, even if they had infrared detection, but only an idiot would leave such an important building without any surveillance. Unless it was a trap, of course.

As they placed the C4-styled bombs down, Davook froze as he heard voices approaching from around the corner, the opposite direction from the checkpoint. The voices were speaking

quietly, too quietly, and the footsteps were inaudible. Who would be trying to walk so quietly at this time of night?

He quickly grabbed Torvok's arm, who had not yet heard them. Torvok's hearing must have not been quite as sharp as Davook's, because he jerked his head up and looked at Davook questioningly. Davook pressed a finger to his lips, beckoning a thumb in the direction he had heard the voices approaching from. The two of them nodded at each other and quickly activated their full shadow-walking abilities as they jumped forwards to another nearby alleyway, their activated abilities increasing their stealth to unprecedented levels.

Of course, it took much more magical energy, going from half to full shadow-walking power, but it was necessary in this time of crisis. Stealing a glance back as they jerked around the alley, Davook blinked twice as three Enforcers quickly sprinted around the corner, aiming their guns at foes that were no longer there.

He started to continue moving, but then did a double take as something caught his eye. Two of the Enforcers were wearing black. Black level Enforcers were the highest ranked of all the colors, possessing very strong abilities unlike those of their comrades. However, there was a smaller, thinner Enforcer leading the two of them. He wore a white uniform, a color Davook had never seen before.

As Davook had that thought, the one in white spoke up. "They're gone. I know I sensed them."

He pulled his head back around the corner as his breathing slowed to a crawl. That voice... the white Enforcer was a female. What the hell? Females couldn't be Enforcers. Everyone knew that.

"We're aborting the mission. They'll see the charges in seconds. Let's go." Davook cursed as he and his friend quickly fled the scene, ducking into a manhole as they silently lifted, climbed in, and replaced the cover in moments.

A female Enforcer... this was new. They may have failed the mission, but sometimes intel was more useful than outright destruction. Perhaps they wouldn't get the shit beat out of them when Satan heard about the failure.

Daisy felt her heart pause, as she glanced down and saw several small devices at the base of the building. Normally she wouldn't have seen them, but as her father had taught her, anywhere a demon goes, death was sure to follow. "Bombs. There's bombs here. Stand back, I'll render them inert." She shot her hand forwards, as the bomb disappeared, sucked into a place it would never be able to cause any damage. This ability consumed a lot of energy and it only worked on small objects, but it was perfect for this sort of thing. "Luckily, you had me here."

The two men nodded silently as she quickly moved around the building, putting each device inside the special place she had learned about several years before. She wasn't sure where she sent them, but it was not anywhere on Earth. She couldn't go there, but the place was creepy enough that she'd never want to.

She panted slightly as she popped open her visor to wipe her face down. She was a beautiful young girl, having just turned seventeen this year. Next year she'd be old enough to legally smoke and drink, not that she wanted that. Her uncle did more than enough for the both of them.

As she wiped the sweat off, she closed her faceplate up again. "What's going on with that checkpoint?" Her soft and beautiful feminine voice would usually be enough to activate any man's primal urges, but she spoke with such a plainness, derived from her uncle over the years, that despite all of her beauty and her lilting voice, she came off as more of a tomboy than anything else.

"Someone dropped some fireworks in a dumpster. Gave the locals a fright. Probably those two you sensed, princess."

The black level Enforcer snickered slightly inside his suit. So this was the supposed White level Enforcer, the most powerful of all the candidates? Ridiculous. She was just a little girl. A cutie too, but a little girl nonetheless. Even if she were Stonewall's daughter or whatever, he wasn't intimidated. Just a little kid who got her authority from her daddy. Stupid little girls like her needed to be put in their place once in a while.

Daisy didn't miss the slight though. "Don't call me 'Princess'. I'll have your rank stripped for insubordination."

"Of course." His tone indicated he didn't buy it.

Daisy turned to face him. In the blink of an eye, she quickly read his mind, her telepathy having become far more seasoned over the years as her uncle had trained her to be a spy that few knew about, allowing him to dig up dirt on political enemies and other such persons. "Douglas Green, was it? What an interesting name. How would you like to be dropped to green rank, mister *Green*?"

The man frowned as he flicked his eyes over to his pal, Eddie. Eddie wasn't about to give him any help. He turned his gaze back to the little girl in front of him. "Telepathy and some weird vanishing power, huh? Dual abilities are pretty rare, even for a black level Enforcer. Maybe I was wrong about you."

"That's cute. You only have one ability. No matter how strong it is, you're no match for me. Especially now that I know exactly how it works." Daisy popped open her faceplate as she

smiled a sickeningly sweet grin at the man who towered a foot above her. "Tell you what, I'm a good girl. I'll give you three options. You can beg for forgiveness right now, you can have your rank stripped, or you can fight me. If you fight me and win, you keep your rank. No, in fact, I'll make sure you're promoted to head of this department. But if you lose, you'll be sent to the Peeler. So, what will it be?"

Douglas frowned at the tiny little girl who was so incredibly deserving of a punch to the face. "I don't care who your daddy is, sweetheart. I worked for years to get where I am. I ain't gonna apologize for anything."

"I expected that much. You big burly men are so predictable." Daisy took a few dainty steps back as she smiled. "A fight it is, then! I'm pretty pissed we lost those demons, so I hope you won't mind if I take some anger out on you?"

Douglas gritted his teeth as he clenched his fist. *This little bitch.* "I'm a gentleman, girly. I'll let you have the first shot. Try to make it a little harder than a stiff breeze. Not like it matters anyway." He smiled, as he readied himself for whatever she'd throw at him. *It's not like she can break through my defenses. That's why my codename is Defender. I'm invincible against any attack.*

Daisy's smile turned slightly crooked as an odd glint appeared in her eye. "All righty! It's your funeral, I suppose." *I'm so glad he has that ability. He'll really be able to take a lot of abuse. I need to work out this kink in my neck somehow.*

Eddie glanced back and forth between the two of them uneasily. Discreetly, he took several steps back. He wanted to be no part of this engagement.

Amy and Jorge shivered as they glanced out their window at the local ISA. The heater had been broken for a week and the electricity on this block was shoddy. Spending all the country's money on the war effort instead of rebuilding infrastructure had that effect. The viewscreen on the wall displayed several reports on the number of victims of the demons, who had been steadily increasing as of late. *Too many attacks, if you ask me.* Amy turned and smiled as her daughter walked into the room.

"Mommy, I want a bedtime story."

Amy nodded quietly. "Alright, baby. I'll be there in a minute, okay?"

Amy nearly jumped in fright as a horrific scream could be heard in the distance. It sounded like a man was having his hand smashed with a hammer, over and over again. Repeating every few seconds, his wail of agony sent shivers down her spine.

Without waiting to be asked, Jorge quickly got up and closed the window. "Christ, what the hell is going on out there?"

Amy shook her head as she got up and walked over to her daughter. "Don't worry about it. We live next door to the ISA. This is probably one of the safest places in all of London. I'm going to go read Sarah a story."

Jorge glanced out the window in the direction of the sound, his stomach flip-flopped as he saw a sight no person would want to see. "Y-yeah. You go do that. I'll be... I'll be... back in bed in a bit."

He cringed as the poor man was brutalized over and over, his horrific wailing muted only somewhat by the closed window. Blinking quickly, he quickly got up and walked over to the viewscreen, turning the volume up to drown out the sounds from outside.

The News personality, John Locke, announced the local news as always. "Yesterday, in Bahrain, several demons were captured by the forces of our glorious leader, Supreme Commander Stonewall. Their failed guerilla attack is proof that our security measures have proven to be quite effective at slowing them down, even stopping them in many cases. Sources close to the Supreme Commander indicate that he is preparing for an assault on their headquarters, located in a secured part of the Displacement Zone in North America. Should this attack be successful, it will go far in preventing their spread, even beginning to reduce the numbers they are able to send at us. Several Department of National Security sources have indicated that several hundred billion of these demons exist, meaning until we can find a way to effectively eliminate them in large numbers, the lockdown in our cities will continue for an unknown time into the future. Now for Tammy with a special radiation report. Tammy?"

"Thanks, John. Sources inside the Bureau of Environmentalism indicate that the fallout from the 7/18 nuclear bombing last year is being successfully contained. While Wales may not be inhabitable for another hundred years or so, the brutal attack has reminded us of why we fight to bring an end to the existence of the demons. The fallout is no longer expected, at the least, to drift over towards Dublin as the authorities have put a lot of focus on weather control in that area. Due to this, the evacuation order has been cancelled."

Jorge rubbed his lip quietly, as he realized the horrible screams outside his window had finally stopped. *Thank god, I couldn't stand to listen to that for a moment longer.* He shook his head as he turned off the viewscreen and headed towards Sarah's bedroom. Pausing at the doorway, he listened as his wife read Sarah her favorite bedtime story, *The Secret Garden*.

He lingered in the doorway for several minutes, listening, until Amy's voice slowed to a crawl. Sarah had fallen asleep faster than usual. Carefully, Amy got up and walked over to the

doorway, the lights in the room fading out as she exited.

The two of them walked silently to their bedroom, closing the door to where only a crack remained. As she pulled off her shirt and pants and crawled into bed, he followed suit as the two of them snuggled up to each other.

Neither were in the mood for anything particularly frisky tonight. The air, lately, had been dreadful. There was something about the city these days that didn't lend itself to romance or anything sweet like that. Amy sighed.

"What happened out there?"

Jorge swallowed as he remembered the scene he had glimpsed. "Nothing good. Looks like some Enforcers had a personal dispute."

"They're fighting among themselves now? Gods, when will it end?"

"I don't know." He reached up and scratched his nose as Amy wrapped her arms around him from behind, pressing herself against his tanned body. "Maybe we should homeschool Sarah. Everyone's doing it, these days. All the materials are available on the Holo-net. Safer than having her walk or take a bus, and it's not like my hazard pay is going to wear out anytime soon."

Amy nodded slowly. "I've been thinking about that myself. Should I re-enlist? Maybe in a couple years? I still have pull with the right people."

Jorge creased his brow. "I don't know. Maybe we should find some work in the civilian sector. Do you really want to work for... for that man?"

Amy sighed. "He's not all bad, you know. It seems dire, but you've seen the reports. They look like us. Would you rather let them into the city to bomb us again? These measures are important."

"It's chaos out there. Nobody knows what the hell they're doing." Jorge pressed his face into his pillow as he felt his wife's gaze on his back. "They're just a bunch of strongmen playing the goons for a man who thinks himself a dictator."

"Come on, that's not fair. The last major attack nearly hit us, you know. Another hundred miles to the east and we wouldn't be here. What do you expect him to do with that kind of threat?"

Jorge stayed silent for a few moments as he mulled it over. "...Yeah. Maybe you're right. I dunno." His gravelly voice choked up as he thought about the man outside. Was this legal, now? Street brawls? This could hardly be called acceptable. If civilization wasn't kept intact, what was

the point? Turning into barbarians just to try and stave off monsters was hardly the ideal solution.

"Maybe. Who knows? The only thing I know is how much I love you." Amy smiled as she pressed herself upwards to kiss the back of his neck.

Jorge smirked. "You always get your way. But not this time. I'm taking the lead tonight." He flipped himself over and pressed his chest against hers aggressively, as she leaned her head back.

"Oh? Well, don't keep me in suspense."

As it turned out, perhaps there was in fact room for romance in this tortured metropolis.

Part 311a:

Space. The final frontier.

These are the voyages of the starship... uh... Mothership. That sounds rather clunky, now that I think about it. Maybe the Mothership starship? The Mothership Enterprise? No, that would be silly.

Our continuing mission: To explore strange new worlds, to seek out new life and new civilizations. (I mean, Umi has already informed me there's no other life in this galaxy than Earth and Volgarius, but a man can dream I suppose.) And uh also TO BOLDLY GO WHERE NO MAN HAS GONE BEFORE!

Alright, not really. It's more like a sightseeing tour while I also sort of look for new worlds I might make habitable for humanity, should the worst happen... but that really doesn't matter, I guess. Exploring the galaxy has been much more fun than constantly fighting or trying to save the universe.

Over the last decade, Amelia, Harold, Helen and I have been to many interesting places... we've seen a lot of things. Being able to manufacture Trifrancium means I can travel around the galaxy at ridiculous speeds. Making enough for an entire fleet takes far too long, but for a single ship, it's a simple enough process. At warp 9, it takes only a day and a half to travel 14,000 light-years to Volgarius' previous location, and I can easily replenish my Trifrancium reserves faster than my ship can use them up.

Because the majority of my clones are either on this ship or in the special dimension I created a few years ago, only a dozen or so are left to monitor activities on Earth. The special clone, Agent X, has been sending me a lot of troubling news lately. Sadly, this has cut my extended vacation short and we're on our way back to Earth now.

My thoughts are interrupted by Amelia as she meanders into view.

"What are you up to?"

Her question is less out of interest, more because she seems to hang around me a lot nowadays. I'm not sure if it's because of boredom or something else, but I have no reasons to complain.

I peek over and take in her figure. She's aged a few more years, visibly speaking, and looks to be in her very early 20's. The aging process for her is slower than a normal human, but very visible. She doesn't look like a child anymore... actually, if I'm being honest, she's incredibly

attractive. I have to keep my guard up around her, since Arthur constantly nags me about how dangerous she is... but I'm beginning to wonder about that. She hasn't done a single bad thing in almost twenty years. Hell, she's performed less evil acts than I have, given I destroyed an entire goddamn planet.

"I'm just looking at some reports Agent X sent me. Look at this... they've instated a curfew." I slide some papers over to her. Lately, I've started using physical paper, since it can't be intercepted like data can. Earth's technological parity with Volgarius, pre-destruction, is leaping upwards at an incredible rate.

Amelia slides into a chair, leaning over the table as her hair spills from behind her over her shoulders. It's so long now, at least three feet. It was always somewhat long in the past, but now it seems to gain a few inches every year. I once asked if she'd like to cut it and she seemed horrified at the thought.

As she glances at the paper, she shrugs. "What's a curfew?"

"Ah, right. It's a word that means you have to be in bed at a certain time, or in the case of the government, it means all citizens must be indoors by a certain hour. Usually, if they're not, they get thrown in jail or punished in some other way."

Amelia frowns. "That sounds pretty bad. Are you going to take over, then? Is it time to remove him from power?"

Amelia's voice is deeper than it used to be, and her childlike excitable nature has taken a backseat to a more mature, analytical style. She used to be very quick to rush to judgement, but now she seems calm, cool, and collected. This is further evidenced by how seriously she takes any competition, including something insignificant, like an occasional game of chess. Actually, I keep losing to her, lately.

"No. It's not my place. Besides, as far as I can tell, despite the harsh conditions the humans are living under, this all seems to be done with positive intentions. The demons dropped a nuclear bomb on a major city close to humanity's capital. That's alarming. If the demons really have set up forward bases on Earth, and especially over where the United States of America used to be, there's very likely to be several such nuclear weapons in that place. He's right to be cautious... I would be too."

Amelia continues reading through the report, setting it aside a few moments later as a look of boredom passes over her face. "What is the meaning of life?"

I feel my eye twitch at the random change of topic. "Uh, come again?"

"I've been thinking about it a lot, lately. I'm immortal, you're immortal, demons are immortal, angels are mostly immortal, gods are immortal, and the Volgrim were also immortal. Only humans, until the discovery of nanobots, weren't immortal. But..." Amelia's forehead creases in a sort of adorable manner. "...I've been talking with mother, and she says that it's best not to worry about the future. When I do think about it, it makes me kind of... scared. We might live to see the end of the universe, you know?"

"Maybe. Then again, who knows. A star might explode and kill us or something. Anything can happen in this timeline."

I feel my smile falter as I say those words. Did I really just say that? Yeah, I did. I killed her, with a supernova. Or rather, I didn't, but Hoarhiim did. Still, I feel like it was my fault somehow, and yet here I am joking about it.

"Sorry." I apologize for some reason, the word slipping out before I can stop it.

Her smile slips away as well. "Why are you apologizing?"

"Nothing. It's not important."

She and I stare awkwardly at each other for a moment before I break eye contact and stare off to the side. Shit, I'm feeling guilty. I killed the her that murdered an entire planet. She was evil, then. She's not evil right now... so long as repentance is a thing. If one can atone for their sins, then they should be judged based on their current actions.

"Jason. There's something you're not telling me, isn't there?" Amelia's oddly perceptive mind these days comes back to bite me.

I shift uneasily in my seat. "There's a lot I haven't told you, won't tell you, and simply can't tell you. Not just you, but nobody else in the universe right now. I have to bear that burden alone."

Amelia nods slowly, as the amiable atmosphere from earlier is all but gone now. "All right. I'll be in the training room. If you want, you can come join me in a bit."

I nod at her and smile weakly. "Yeah, I'll be there soon. I just need to get in contact with Agent X first."

Amelia leaves the room, and now I'm alone with my thoughts.

All alone, just like I was when this all started. What do I do next?

Dosena sighed as the last beam was finally soldered together. This was the final step to completing the frame of the new recreational area. Frankly, none of the Volgrim here had any desire to have 'fun', but one of Jason's clones had suggested that it would be better than simply mulling around and doing nothing.

What did he expect though? She had no goal anymore. Unarin had always been the one to lead the Volgrim to new destinations, to expand their borders, to make sure they had something to strive for.

How long had it been? Dosena had lost track of time here. The days seemed longer than the ones on Volgarius. The star that had been created was much yellower than the one she had lived under for millions of orbital cycles. This one was likely based off the star that warmed Jason's homeworld. It functioned, of course, but it just wasn't right.

Leaving this place was impossible. Several times, she had debated killing the clone that monitored this zone, but the gesture would be fruitless. Jason could just summon another, and she still wouldn't be able to escape. She knew little about how his abilities worked, only that a being like him who could create an entire world inside of a totally different dimension was not bound by the laws of physics that she knew.

However, there was something going on. For a long time now, the clone here had been... uncomfortable. It wasn't like he would simply start fearing her fellow Volgrim from out of nowhere, but every time he looked into her eyes, she was able to sense a vague feeling of... guilt? Sadness? She wasn't very adept at understanding the subtle nuances of human emotions, but there was something under the surface.

Just as he could not read her mind, however, she could not read his. It hadn't always been this way. When she first met the original, so far in the past, reading his mind had been as easy as plucking a plant out of the ground. His incredible abilities had somehow allowed him to block her out effortlessly. She didn't know how he did it, but she did know his mental barriers never faltered. Even in sleep, she had to focus her mind to prevent intrusion, but he had no such issues. His defense was impenetrable.

Dosena sighed, as she lifted the steel beam up into the air with her telekinetic power. Setting it in place, she held it there while the other Volgrim rushed around, making sure it was bolted and soldered into place perfectly. The instruments they used were primitive and crude, but effective in practice.

Finally, she wandered back to her living quarters. If they needed her again, they would let her know.

"We'll be lucky to make it another hundred years, at this rate." Zeus and the archangel Gabriel stood atop a skyscraper that had been recently constructed in the heart of London. It was supposed to be one of the ten biggest buildings in the world, now that most of the other ones had been destroyed by various causes over the last hundred years. When one explained it

in that way, however, it simply made the building seem far less impressive, given it was only a hundred stories tall.

Gabriel shook his head sadly. "The humans deny our help at every opportunity. They're shunning us. The only people who give us any spiritual energy are those in the Church of Retribution. They seem to believe that we are agents of the Creator, sent to wipe out all unbelievers, as well as the demons."

Zeus groaned as he rubbed his temples. "A crazy fanatical cult. Is this really all that's left of the once almighty Christian and Arabic empires? Even Hinduism, Taoism, and all the other Eastern religions are dead. Humans used to always gravitate towards religion in times of crisis. What changed?"

"You've got it all wrong. Humans weren't looking for religion, they simply wanted something secure they could put their faith in." A voice rang out from behind Zeus and Gabriel, as the two of them spun around in alarm.

"Satan?! What are you doing here?" Gabriel clenched his fists together as he stared down the intimidating devil that stood before him. Alongside Satan, a female succubus stood, her body and curves making even a hardened archangel like himself feel slightly intoxicated.

"Zeus, Gabriel. A pleasure. It's been so long since we had a little chat."

Zeus glared at the devil. "Why are you here? Come to pick a fight? The humans are at least partially still on our side, and I doubt even you can stand up to their war machines. If we make a commotion, they'll be upon us in minutes."

Belial sighed as she rolled her eyes. "Calm down, Captain Sparkles. If we wanted a fight, we'd have brought along more than just Satan and little ol' me, don't you think?"

Zeus reflexively flexed his fist as he eyeballed the sultry femme fatale. He could tell in a glance that she was more than a pretty face. Those small arms and lithe limbs held many secrets, and she was surely an accomplished fighter, based on the aura she exuded. Best not to underestimate her.

"A talk, is it? What could you possibly have to say that I'd want to hear?"

Satan flicked his gaze out and over the edge of the skyscraper, to the city below. This high up, its sounds were muted, but at least somewhat audible. It was a city in distress. Red and blue lights lit up the night, far below them, as the sound of sirens could be heard from all over.

"Things really aren't going well for you, are they? They aren't going well for me, either." Satan licked his lips suggestively as he held frame against that of the King of Gods.

"Heh, so I've heard." Gabriel let a small smile slip as he chuckled quietly. "It seems the humans are taking you out with ease now, as I always knew they would. I didn't think they would reduce you to such a pitiful state, but clearly you haven't been holding out quite so well."

"That's cute. Admit it, we're both in dire straits. If the humans kept their current technology levels, my people would be able to hold out for another millennium or so, but that isn't going to happen. Instead, they're going to keep improving and killing more and more of us with improved efficiency. And then for yourself, you need a constant supply of spiritual energy. Since you're losing energy much faster than you can replace it, you're going to start losing angels left and right." Satan leaned forwards slightly as a smile spread across his face. "That is, if you haven't already."

Zeus's eye twitched. "I am aware of both our situations. I don't need you to remind me... foul creature. Get on with it. Why are you here?"

Satan put on a mock expression of indignity. "I can't believe you would insult me so! Why, I always thought of the two of us as friends! Surely you don't continue to hold any dislike towards me for silly actions that happened in our past?"

Gabriel sneered. "Cut the jokes."

His face falling back to a neutral expression, Satan breathed in sharply. "Fine. I have a proposition. I hate you, and you hate me, we both agree on that. However, if this continues, both of us will watch helplessly as all of our kind die under the tyranny of the humans. The humans may not be your enemy now, but you and I both can see a shift coming. They've already started shunning you. Once they eliminate my kind, they will turn towards you next. Unlike the demons, you're already greatly weakening due to lack of spiritual energy. Your current position is... how should I say it... tenuous, at best."

Satan snickered to himself. "Hehe, I just had a funny thought. I so desperately want to get revenge on you, but if you don't choose to work with me, I will likely at least die knowing that you'll be next. At least that thought will be a comforting one in my final moments."

Gabriel stifled himself from showing any outward emotions. "As if. Everyone here knows that if it came down to that, you'd merely create a small dimension where the humans couldn't find you and you'd simply go into hiding, the lives of your own kind be damned. You care nothing for their lives, despite your outward pretensions."

Satan immediately snapped his eyes over to the archangel as a sneer formed on his lips. "How dare you. You've no room to talk yourself. You couldn't care less about a single one of the angels born from your pet project. At best, you might care about the other archangels and some of the higher ranked gods, but you are a hypocrite in every meaning of the word. You-"

Belial cut him off quickly. "Calm down, my love. We're not here for that. Remember why we came here?"

Satan seethed for a moment before he swallowed and spoke again, more carefully this time. "Right. Here's my proposal. I'm not saying that we need to work together, but I have a solution that will benefit the both of us, and it's regarding that cult you mentioned before."

Gabriel and Zeus both narrowed their eyes simultaneously. Zeus pursed his lips as he realized the reason the demon might have come here. "Go on. I'm listening."

Part 312a:

If he were being totally honest, Ben would tell anyone who asked that the Hypersuits were by far the pinnacle of war perfection. Coupled with the Dartfighters, humanity had created two weapons that were indestructible and highly destructive.

But, given that Stonewall had chosen to oust Jason from his position as humanity's divine protector, these new war-machines, the Micro-Dreadnaughts, had to take up the slack. And really, they were powerful in their own right.

As his company pressed down the halls of the labyrinth, he checked his energy scanner. Several blips had been visible for a few minutes now, and judging by the distance, a couple more turns would bring them into view.

Really though, if the demons couldn't hear the humans coming, they weren't trying. The Micro-Dreadnaughts, despite the name, were quite massive. They barely even fit into the hallways of the labyrinth, and the lone Micro-Dreadnaught he had received authorization to bring along for this mission scraped the walls loudly, even as its massive bipedal frame stomped along, each step sounding like a sledgehammer smashing into concrete.

Certainly, the Hypersuits were a more efficient, sleeker weapon of mass murder... but the Micro-Dreadnaughts just felt *better*. One could hardly blame the demons if they were quaking in their boots as they heard the rumbling in the deep.

"Exalt, we're reaching the red zone. We've just now crossed the two mile mark back to the portal. If this goes south, it's going to be a long run back."

Ben nodded at the young girl who had just spoken. Despite her youthful appearance, she was a seasoned fighter, and one he knew personally.

"I'm not worried about that, Daisy. As long as you get out, the worst effect will be nullified. You've got enough energy, right?"

She nodded quietly as another corner became visible up ahead, though it was hard to see given the massive frame of the construct was impeding their view. "Yes. Getting to the portal should be easy. If I'm correct, I might even have enough energy to bring you with m-"

"That's not necessary. You're the Supreme Commander's daughter, your life comes first. Understand?" Ben coughed suddenly as a rasp appeared in his throat. The nano-cancer wasn't improving, these days. The side effects were quite unpleasant. "If your father finds out that you

died because you ran out of energy sending me back, he'll skin me alive anyway. I can handle myself, don't you worry."

Daisy smiled slightly, as the Micro-Dreadnaught suddenly came to a stop up ahead. "HOSTILES SIGHTED. ENGAGING NOW."

In the blink of an eye, the massive machine leveled a two-ton energy cannon at several small imps who squealed in fright. Before they had a chance to react, the lumbering behemoth fired a blast of anti-energy, searing their bodies at the atomic level. Swiveling slightly, the Dreadnaught aimed its single red 'eye' towards a flash of movement in front of it. "SHADOW-WALKERS. ANTI-STEALTH PULSE ACTIVATING NOW."

A small pulse of energy erupted from every crevasse of the machine, as it surged outwards at half the speed of sound, creating a deep WUMP as it impacted the walls and the people behind it. Four shadow-walkers stumbled and fell as the pulse of anti-energy, as weak as it was, caused mental feedback. Used mainly as a method of mass-stunning several medium to weak enemies, this particular technique was especially effective against those who were already channeling large amounts of energy to a specific spell... such as a shadow-walker.

They stumbled around dumbly as they tried to shake off the effects of the pulse, but it was too late for them. The lumbering juggernaut fired twice in succession, each shot wiping the energy from their bodies, causing a dissolving effect on their bodies as they vanished from existence.

It had been just under fifteen seconds, and the death machine had already killed a dozen demons. Ben stumbled back to his feet, realizing with a start that Daisy was laying on the ground, holding her head and moaning. "Shit, you all right sweetheart? Fuck, your dad's going to kill me."

Daisy mumbled something incoherent, as she shook her head and words managed to form themselves in her mind once again. "I-I'm fine. I just wasn't ready for that. I *thought* we programmed these machines to give a little more warning before they blew off a pulse like that. Good way to hit our own forces."

The machine continued to lumber forwards as Ben gave her a hand up, pulling her to her feet. "We did, but shadow-walkers are extremely dangerous. They can kill ten men in the blink of an eye before we know they're even there. They are the lone exception."

Ben shot a glance back, as several of his red level enforcers were also climbing up to their feet, checking each other for mental feedback and whatnot. "That being said, maybe we can program an exception for when we're inside the labyrinth. Not like those walkers had a way of getting past the Dreadnaught in these close hallways."

"Yeah, do that." Daisy quickly walked back to help one enforcer in particular, who had just vomited. "You there! Are you alright? Do you need medical attention?"

The man fought mightily but tears erupted from his eyes as he struggled to speak. Daisy nodded quickly as she placed her hand on the back of his head. "Don't worry, I'll get you. Everyone else, go on ahead. I'll keep a small contingent here. We'll catch up shortly."

Ben started to object, but he paused, seeing who that particular enforcer was. "Agent Dawson? He's a stealth-class, very promising ability he's got, too. Alright, you can hold back. We'll press forwards, but catch up quickly. It's incredibly dangerous here."

Daisy nodded as she continued to send healing pulses through the man's brain.

Ben and the rest continued forwards, leaving Daisy and a dozen Enforcers behind as they pressed forwards.

Ben glowered as he stomped away. *Damn, I hope I don't regret this.*

"When the light shines down from the skies above... that will be the moment! The moment of truth! Only the true believers will be saved on that fateful day! We cannot allow ourselves to be blinded by feelings of nostalgia, or to be complacent! If you have family, or friends, they will not be saved unless they preach the news of Retribution!"

Preacher Clarence yelled mightily as his congregation looked on in awe. "Think, everyone, about the lives of your children! The lives of your sons and daughters! Do you want to see them die? Of course not. Behold! God has given us a way out, a way to survive the apocalypse! When he delivers his divine punishment upon the demons, and the warmongers, and those who have taken the elixir of the nanobot, and the homosexuals, fear not! For we are not vile like the sinners, we are not tainted by their actions! Pray daily, beg him for forgiveness of your sins! Be proud of your clean, wholesome heritage! Bow down to no man, and follow no other gods, for He will see, and He will know you!"

The congregation clapped loudly, several of the younger members up front grinning madly as they exchanged knowing looks with one another.

The First Church of the Retribution had been established nearly a decade ago by this very man speaking. Preacher Clarence was a man, who, as he had preached about on many occasions, had spoken with an angel himself. None could verify his claims, of course, but everyone had seen the angels with their own eyes. His story must be true.

Born from a single mother household, Clarence had lived on the streets after his mother had committed suicide, fending for himself from age 10 and onwards. Drugs, sex, and even violence had been the mark of his life. Clearly, for a man as vile as he, to make such a dramatic

transformation... it could only be caused by something from on high... or so went the rumors, anyway.

Clarence paused for a moment to sip water from a glass that had been specially custom made by one of his congregational members. It was a gaudy thing, with the pattern of an angel that had her outstretched arms make a circle for him to hold onto it with, and the backside of the cup had two wings sprouting outwards. Really, it was such an ugly thing, but given the member of the church was still in attendance and donated quite a hefty amount daily to their coffers... he didn't mind playing along.

Clarence wiped his brow with a towel that he had set on his podium. It was an easy job, speaking once a day for a mere hour at a time, and the fools ate up everything he said as if he was the mouth of god himself. Still, he appreciated their patronage, and all too often they were happy to donate extra when he spoke of 'administrative fees' and 'crushing debt' incurred by the central authorities. Actually, no such happenings ever occurred, as they cared little for his microcosm of a cult, but it didn't hurt him to lie. *Just a little.*

He returned to his position at the front of the stage, his hands trembling. "I... I had a vision last night. A vision of the Archangel Michael! He spoke to me in... in a dream! He spoke of the Great Retribution! A calamity from the sky that will wipe out all evil on Earth! A terrible catastrophe that will-!"

As he droned on, the front door flew open, causing him to pause mid-sentence. The audience turned back to look.

An old man stood, slowly ambling forwards as he leaned on a heavily gnarled cane.

"Oh, I'm sorry, did I interrupt anything, father?" The old man smiled kindly.

Clarence felt something odd, deep inside his heart. This old man was not one he had seen before. Best to give him a gracious welcome.

"Not at all! Welcome, sir! We love the elderly here, so wise and insightful they are! Why have you come to visit our church on this blessed day, good sir?"

The old man shrugged lightly, as he continued to slowly amble towards the front. "Oh, no reason, really. I heard there was one last man of god in this world, one who understood the old ways. I've come to see if he's the man everyone speaks of."

"I certainly should hope so!" Clarence quickly moved forwards towards the old man. "I am he. Father Clarence is my name. And you, what might yours be?"

The old man cocked an eyebrow knowingly. "I have been known by many names over my long life. But you might know me best by my contemporary name. I am Raphael, second

Archangel of Heaven!"

In the blink of an eye, the old man dropped his cane to his side as light began to shine from his body. His clothing trembled slightly, as a massive set of wings sprouted out, exploding to the sides, ten feet in both directions.

One of the teenagers in the audience quickly tapped his holowatch as he aimed it at the spectacle before him. Normally, this place of worship would not allow such unclean technology, but his parents were too transfixed by the sight before them, they failed to notice him recording this.

"I have come from Heaven itself to give you my blessing! We have judged you and determined you to be most holy! Continue telling people of our work, and your reward will be most eternal indeed!"

Clarence felt his lip tremble. *Son of a bitch. An angel actually came here? I just made all this crap up, but I was right?*

He started to speak, but Sister Margaret, a very old woman in the seats up front, grabbed her chest as she struggled to breathe. Collapsing down, she fell to the ground wheezing.

"Heart attack! She's having a heart attack!" A young man sitting a row down leaped to his feet and ran over to her, but he was blocked by Raphael, who had moved to her side in an instant.

"Fear not, my child. Do you doubt the will of the Creator?"

The young man shook his head slowly as his hands trembled mightily. He glanced from the old woman to the angel and back. Unlike most people of this generation, she had rejected the nanotechnology, choosing to live a life of growing old and dying. It was natural that she would eventually perish, but still, few had really expected it to happen.

Raphael leaned down to the woman as she shook on the floor, her mind slipping away. "Go now, pass on, and be with us in Heaven."

As she shook one final time, her eyes rolled up into her head, and she ceased to move. She had finally passed away, at the tender old age of 97.

Clarence stared down at her corpse. *Curses, that old bitch dropped a fat stack in the plate every Friday. She was an important source of revenue.*

Raphael quickly rose to his full height as he stared at the church members. "Fear not! She has become one with us in Heaven! Look! I shall summon her spirit here!"

With an overly dramatic display of light, Raphael sent a quick telepathic message to Gabriel. *An old woman just died, name was Margaret Grey. Send her down as quickly as possible.*

The crowd stared at him expectantly as moments passed. Raphael breathed silently as his eyes flicked back and forth, his arms still upraised dramatically.

"Mommy, is she coming back?" A little girl in the front row practically yelled the question out as her mother hushed her quickly.

"Quiet, you're embarrassing me!"

Seconds turned into a minute, as Raphael swallowed carefully. *Come on, my old arms can't hold up like this any longer.*

Finally, he received a reply. *I've got her now. Teleporting her directly to you.*

Another flash of light blasted out as the old woman appeared up front, near the altar. "Good heavens, I'm back?"

"Indeed, young lady. You are now an agent of the Creator himself." Raphael lowered his arms, choking down a sigh of relief. "As will all of you become, when the Day of Retribution arrives! Put your heart and soul into this movement, make the gods proud, and you shall be rewarded with truly eternal life in Heaven!"

The audience roared with applause as everyone shot looks of incredulity at each other. Some, of course, had harbored many doubts over these last few years, but now there could be no doubt. The angels were real, and they had sent an *archangel* to speak with the flock personally. This had to be a sign from on high, indeed!

As they clapped furiously, Raphael cocked his head back slightly, whispering to Father Clarence. "As for you, I'd like to speak with you in *private*."

Clarence nodded numbly as he swallowed slowly. *Fuck.*

I clapped my hands together, as I sat cross-legged on the bed. Meditation was something I had spent the last few years working on, and a great side-effect of it had been the ability to put myself into a trance so I could speak with my mentor, King Arthur, whenever I wished. Exhaustion be damned.

Closing my eyes, I hummed one long, deep note to myself, as I held my hands together carefully.

It took a minute or so, but eventually I began to feel blackness wash over my vision, as my mind once again entered a place I had seen many times before.

Hmm, actually, this place was different. I mean, I knew what it was almost immediately. Stonehenge. A place created by an unknown group of people, ten thousand years ago, possibly more. Now, why might Arthur be here, today?

"Jason. Glad to see you." Arthur smiled as he took a sip of wine. Beckoning to his side, another glass of wine was sitting on the steps just outside the circle of massive boulders. I walked over, raising the glass up to my mouth in one smooth motion as I took my seat.

The taste was delicious. I used to taste nothing in this fake realm of his, but perhaps now I've developed some mental discipline. Things have taste here now. I can smell odors and aromas that I couldn't before.

I smacked my lips with satisfaction as I finished my glass of wine. "Things aren't going so well on Earth, I've heard."

"Agent X, right? He's your deep cover guy?"

"Yep. The best clone I've ever made. Very specialized for what he does."

Arthur shrugs. "Things are never going well on Earth. What else is new?"

I tap my lip thoughtfully, as I debate how to bring up the topic that's been bugging me. "Arthur, I don't know how to ask this, but here goes nothing. Listen, when we first met, you told me you were the most powerful hero of all time."

Arthur nodded. "Mmm. Yes, that is certainly a thing I said."

"And you said that, despite this proclamation, Amelia cleaned the floor with you."

Arthur narrowed his eyes inquisitively. "Yes. Go on..."

A slight smile was on his face, but my own was stuck in a look of concentration. "See, I've been thinking about my life so far. About power, and how to gain it, and important thresholds to cross. I fought Amelia, in the future. In the end, it was not me that won, but a divine ally that used my body as a vessel."

Arthur raised his eyebrows as he cocked his head slightly. "You managed to beat her? And you told me that you were weaker in the future than you are now."

"Yeah. It's a long story. But the thing is... Amelia had already been defeated once before. But not by me."

"You don't say?" Arthur leaned forwards, his smile gone now. "Jason, what's this all about? You're being more cryptic than usual."

"I have doubts. Many, many doubts. About Amelia, about myself, and about the future. I've changed the future, but I don't think I've changed it enough."

Arthur stared at me silently, not asking any more questions. Apparently, he expected me to continue.

"Err, Arthur... do you know who Joan of Arc is?"

He shook his head slowly. "Can't say I do. Why?"

I felt my gaze drift away from him for a moment. As I thought. Historical records indicate she was born several hundred years after he had died. If he had been sealed inside of Excalibur, with no knowledge of the world around him, then he wouldn't know of her existence.

"Joan of Arc was a female hero. She was born several hundred years after you had sealed yourself inside this blade. And... the thing is... I've never met her before, but every demon that spoke of her, spoke like she was the most powerful hero to have ever lived. In fact, you were never mentioned."

I turned back to Arthur to see he had lowered his eyes. "So that's how it is, then. I suppose, between your birth and my death, I should have known that another hero would emerge, and maybe they might have been more powerful than me. I shouldn't have assumed..."

Arthur paused for a moment, as I could almost see a lightbulb pop above his head. "...You stated that she had defeated Amelia?"

I nodded. "Yes. Not killed though. She merely sealed her inside of a statue, and I... erm... accidentally broke the statue, releasing her."

"Huh. But Amelia isn't sealed inside of a statue now, obviously. So if that's the case... perhaps she failed in this timeline?"

I shook my head quickly. "No. In the future I came from, Amelia defeated Satan, turned him into a puppet, then at some indeterminate time afterwards, she fought and lost to Joan. During our final battle, Amelia mocked me several times, stating that I was nothing compared to Joan. She spoke of Joan almost in a manner of awe. I daresay that while hating the one who sealed her, she also revered her."

Arthur raised a palm face-up nonchalantly. "Who can blame her? This Joan girl... she sounds very impressive. I'd like to meet her someday, if it were possible."

"But that's the thing. There's no way it could be Joan of Arc, even though all the pieces fit together. I mean, it had to be her, yet it couldn't have been."

Arthur chuckled. "Yes, I can see the confusion. Still, if you have the ability to time travel, who is to say that others don't as well? Perhaps Joan was such a mighty hero that she broke the boundaries of time and space. I don't think you're opening your mind to several different possibilities here."

"I guess."

I'm not convinced. Even if she were this crazy time traveling hero, what reason would she have to travel to the future? And why did historical records indicate she died at the age of 19,

burned at the stake? Heh, come to think of it though, the church believed that she used magic which is why they executed her for heresy, and I guess when it's thought of with what I know now, it makes sense. She wasn't just a user of magic, but maybe the most powerful to ever live.

I guess sometimes, they get it right.

After a few moments, I stand up abruptly. "All right, good talk. I need to get back now."

Arthur cocks an eyebrow. "Leaving already? Come, stay a while! Let us drink some mead! What's the rush to get back to boring old politics and women anyway? Both are nothing but trouble!"

"Yeah, but they might affect my physical body, so they matter. Besides, it'll just be a quick chat. I need to see what the moron is up to now. That is, with my own eyes."

"Alright. Whatever." Arthur waved dismissively as a small cup full of booze appeared in front of himself. "Your loss."

Man, when did this legendary hero get so... chummy?

I blink slowly as the artificial universe fades away, and now I'm back in mine.

Harold sends me a mental message. "Hey, kid. Somethin' happened, it's got the big guy on Earth all angry 'n stuff. You'd best git a move on. We'll be arrivin' in 'bout 15 minutes or so."

"What happened?" Stonewall wasn't the sort of person to get angry over nothing. It must be pretty serious.

"Nobody'd tell me a thing. 's all on you, pal."

Fantastic, what a great way to start my day.

Part 313a:

I teleported down to Earth's surface, right in the heart of the London Palace, and smack into the center of chaos. Unlike before, I was not wearing my hypersuit since I didn't want to draw attention to myself. Agent X had already supplied me with a red-level clearance card, so if anyone asked who I was, I could just show it to them and they wouldn't bug me anymore.

Walking forwards quickly, I frowned as a sense of dread filled my body. Several secretaries raced past me, their arms full of various hard copy documents and such. Shoving me out of the way, they didn't even pause to excuse themselves, ignoring me completely. It didn't bother me, but it was the first of many signs that something was going very wrong.

Walking forwards, I arrived in the war room as people frantically moved from screen to screen, pointing and talking with a mixture of fear and nerves as their hands shook.

To my surprise, Ben Brown was in the room. "Do we have any leads? First person to locate the target gets a big fat raise and a huge promotion, understand?"

I swallowed carefully as I walked up to him. He didn't see me at all as he stared ahead, watching a screen update in front of him. Before I reached him, I paused to stare at the screen. Unless I was wrong... it was a three-dimensional map of the Labyrinth? This was exactly the sort of thing I had seen years ago, when I wore the Crown of Solomon inside of it. Several red dots were positioned in various locations, clustered around one sizable area. A great portion of the 3D map was entirely missing though, indicating they hadn't explored enough of the labyrinth to get a true feel for its size yet.

I turned back and spoke up. "Ben. Ben!"

He blinked quickly as he turned to face me. "Yeah? What do you want? I'm busy. Wait, who even are you?"

He frowned slightly as he started to turn away before a spark appeared in his eye. "Jason? Is that you?"

I nodded quickly as I flicked my gaze over to the viewscreen he had been watching. "I came back for a visit, and seems like you guys are having some trouble."

Ben stared at me uneasily for a moment before looking back at the map of the labyrinth. "Nothing we can't handle. You know the rules, Stonewall doesn't want your help. I'm not going over his head for this."

I felt my lips dry up slightly at his words. "Ben, that's not like you. I thought we were friends?"

"Yeah. Times change, people change." Ben didn't turn back to look me in the eye, as he seemed to avoid my gaze.

What happened between us? One day we were going out to destroy the Volgrim homeworld, the next he stopped talking to me for ten years.

I'll have to ask him about it later. "Fine, I get it. Listen, I just need to talk with Stonewall. Where's his office?"

Ben chuckled without sounding amused in the slightest. "You picked a damn shitty time to drop by. He's in the worst mood he's ever been in his life. His niece just got kidnapped by the demons, after all."

I nodded carefully. "He has a niece? Well, that's fine. I don't have to bother him right-" I paused, as I glanced around the room again. "Wait, is that what all this chaos is about? Is he spending humanity's resources just to find one little girl?"

Ben groaned as he turned back to me, irritation in his eyes. "Look, you've been gone a long time, understand? She is very important to him, and probably all of humanity as well. She's not just some little girl. I daresay she's the biggest agent of hope that we have in the war against the demons." Ben coughed as he leaned forwards knowingly. "Basically, now that you're out, she's in, understand?"

I nodded slowly as I sized Ben up. He was so different now from when I knew him. He wasn't the young recruit who excitedly tore apart Volgrim with his bare hands, nor the man who waded into battles haphazardly. He seemed more shrewd, more calm, more... calculating. Then there was the matter of Stonewall's influence. How had the madman changed Ben for the worse?

"Yeah, I get it." I forced a smile, but Ben didn't reciprocate it. "Ben, let me help out. I've got nothing better to do anyway. Where's she located?"

Ben chuckled again as he coughed loudly. "Shit, it doesn't matter. Nobody knows. This fucking maze is gigantic. It's already been two days... she could be anywhere. Like I said though, we've got it under control."

I nodded again as I edged slightly closer to him. "Ben. You know what they say about kidnappings, right? By the third day, the rate of finding the victim drops to 10%. Let me help you. You won't even know I'm there, it'll be in a totally unofficial capacity. I'll even let you take the credit for finding her."

Ben gnawed on his lip as he glanced from me to his viewscreen and back. "I can't just... damn. Fine, whatever. I'll let you help out, *unofficially*, understand? What do you need to get started?"

"Not much. Tell me her name, and give me a picture or a video of what she looks like. The more details, the better."

Ben sighed as he reached down to his holopad. "I can send you some video and picture files. Her name is Daisy Sokolov, age 17. Also, seeing as she's been living with Stonewall for ten years now... don't be too surprised if she knows exactly who you are. The man is not a fan of you. And just make sure you don't threaten her or anything. I'd hate to see you in a casket the next time we meet."

I chortled. "I see you've still got a great sense of humor. I'll save this little girl, don't you worry your little heart."

Ben seemed unamused. "Don't say I didn't warn you. Good luck, kid."

As I turned to walk away, I smiled back at him. "I'm almost three times your age. Respect your elders."

Daisy blinked her eyes slowly as a slight film seemed to break apart in front of her vision. *What happened? I fell asleep? How long have I been here?*

She moaned slightly as a pounding headache and incredible feeling of weakness filled her body. She could barely move at all and seemed to be laying on a cold hard floor of some sort. It was tough to tell though, as the place she was in was barely lit at all, only the tiniest amount of light allowed her to see anything.

Normally, this would be no issue. Her ability to see in any spectrum of ultraviolet or infrared, or many other weird ways, meant she could see in just about any lighting condition. Since this was not the case now, she quickly made a deduction in the span of a few seconds. "Energy nullification." She spoke out loud, her voice weakly echoing off the walls of the tiny room, or holding cell, or whatever it was.

"Yes, energy nullification. Very good, young woman." Daisy shifted her head towards the voice that had spoken. The voice was decidedly female, roughly age 30 or so, and distinctly human sounding, if that were a thing. Of course, age was just a number these days, so her actual age could be anything.

"Who... are you?" Daisy struggled to lift herself up, every movement feeling like she was lifting a boulder while doing a pushup, finally, she rolled into a sitting position as she leaned

back against a wall. Her clothes were damp with sweat, and she panted like an animal, but most magic users couldn't manage even this much in a room like this.

"It shouldn't concern you all that much, but my name is Marie. I'm just an ordinary lady, nothing special about me."

The woman speaking appeared to be standing about five feet away, leaning against the opposite corner of the cell from where Daisy now gasped for breath.

Daisy lifted her arm slowly, bringing it up to wipe her forehead. Despite how cold the floor was, the room itself was unbearably warm, though the older woman didn't seem majorly affected by it. "Why am I here? What happened?"

Marie sighed dramatically. "Your uncle, the leader of humanity, has been a thorn in my side for too long now. I decided to take matters into my own hands. When I sensed an opportunity, I went for it. You, like a stupid and naive child, decided to stay behind in the labyrinth and let the rest of your platoon move forwards without you. A few minutes of them waiting would not have had any adverse effects on the mission, but your stupidity is what let you get caught."

Daisy swallowed heavily as she blinked her eyes, fatigue pouring from every inch of her body. "Haah... but you're a human, right? Why were you in the labyrinth? Why... how did you...?"

Marie clicked her tongue as annoyance set in. "Shut up. I'm not here for small talk. I'm here to deliver a warning. Not to you, little insect, but to your idiot of an uncle. That fool has no clue what he's doing with the serum, he doesn't know the backlash it's going to cause soon. He's playing with an energy few fully understand, except for myself."

Daisy squinted as she carefully examined the pale shadow of a figure in the dark. Her eyes were adjusting slowly to the near pitch-blackness, but it was an uphill struggle. "What are you talking about? I don't understand at all."

Marie started to lash out again, but she instead sighed as she walked over close to Daisy, sitting down beside her as she wrapped her arms around the teen's back. "Listen, sweetheart, you're just a little kid who got sucked into something bigger than you. I understand, I really do. I've read your file, I know what those morons did to you in the black facility, okay? But, see, you're in it, now. You have a responsibility to fill. You're in the position I was when I was your age. You can't get out, so you need to respect the responsibility thrust onto you."

Daisy felt a chill of ice go down her back as she tried to ignore the sudden nonchalance of this strange woman, who had gotten very close and personal in the span of a few seconds. "I... I still don't understand. What do I have to do with any of this?"

Marie paused for a moment as she contemplated the question. "I'll try to explain this simply. Let's say that you have a beehive that produces a certain amount of honey every day. The metaphor won't be perfect, but bear with me. So you have this beehive, and you extract some honey from it every once in a while when the time is right, and everything seems to go just fine."

"Well, suppose, for a moment, that this beehive would produce more potent and tasty honey each time you extracted it, but you were somehow oblivious to this. One day, you find out that you are in debt. You need that honey to pay off this debt, so you can sell it to the market. You also come to find out that the more you extract the honey, the more honey it produces exponentially."

"Well, you have a big edge over the competition now. Your honey is effectively unlimited, and people love it. There are apparently no downsides to extracting this much honey day in and day out, right?"

Daisy swallowed as Marie paused to wait for an answer. "Well, based on this metaphor, I'm guessing there *are* downsides?"

Marie licked her lips lightly, the sound reverberating off the walls in the tiny cell, as insignificant as it was. "Well, the metaphor doesn't work very well, but yes, there are side effects, very very bad ones. Let's just say that each time you draw from that sweet everlasting honey pool, you are slowly angering the bees inside of it. At some point, they will come out, and the revenge will be... intense."

Marie stood up, withdrawing her arm as she spoke quickly. "Lights."

A blast of light shot from every corner of the cell, as Daisy and Marie both winced. "Idiots, who put the setting at 100%? I hate bright light. Fifty percent lighting."

As the light dimmed, both women breathed a sigh of relief. Daisy was still barely sitting up, but now she managed to get a good look at the older woman. With long flowing red hair that tapered off in subtle curls, coupled with the white labcoat of a scientist, Marie wasn't very intimidating when the lights were flicked on.

"Mind if I smoke?" Marie reached into her pocket as she pulled out a pack created by a replicator. This was obvious by the fact that it had no labeling on it whatsoever. "These taste like shit, but at least it's something. I miss my Marbs."

Daisy didn't speak as Marie took a few silent puffs. Daisy didn't mind the smoke, anyway, it reminded her of her uncle Vasily.

Finally, Marie spoke again. "Let me be more clear. There's a reason the United States sealed off Nazi research into Type 3 energy. The Illuminati knows of those effects but doesn't care.

They only want more power, as they always do, and your uncle has proven to be a most useful tool, understand?"

Daisy started to speak, but Marie, ever the talker, interrupted her. "I know you do, you're a smart girl. Listen, it works like this; the heroes have been gaining power since the dawn of time. Each is slightly more powerful than the previous, at least as far as their energy concentration goes. With the exception of once when certain individuals tried to dampen the effect, it merely added to the coming backlash. The Nazi's were the topper."

Daisy squinted as she felt her mind drifting. "I still don't understand a thing you're talking about."

"You know about Judicator, right? I'm sure your uncle has at least mentioned him in passing."

Daisy nodded carefully, the movement feeling like her hundredth pushup in a row.

"Great. See, Judicator is, quite possibly, the most powerful and dangerous hero in existence. The Nazi's, bless their idiot male stupidity, played with fire. They started testing type 3 energy on humans, without making sure of the side effects. Each time someone is given type 3 energy, the next in line will have increased ability. Are you following along yet?"

Daisy shrugged. "I... guess?"

"Maybe I was wrong, you're still a dummy it seems. Anyway, my point is thus... the energy buildup will only affect the next true candidate in line. So because of what those gargantuan morons did with their testing, none of the test subjects survived... but the buildup meant when the current hero died... the next to be born would have colossal, previously untapped abilities."

Daisy felt her heart slam in her chest. "So... Judicator was that hero? He received the buildup?"

"Precisely. But that's only half of the story. The, err, 'individuals' who put a stopper on the power of the heroes... they no longer have the ability to do that anymore. They've been ousted from the place where they created the power of the heroes. So, are you understanding now?"

Daisy nodded, very slightly. "I think so. You're saying... because my uncle, and the, erm, Illuminati... you're saying they've been testing the energy on humans and causing a buildup again?"

Marie swallowed carefully. "Yes. If Judicator dies, when his powers pass on to the next hero, that one will have abilities unlike anything we've ever seen before. Judicator will seem like a small child wielding a spoon against the armies of hell themselves, when this next hero arrives."

Daisy sniffled quietly. "Fine. This is all so much to take in but... I still don't get it. Why me? Why are you telling me this, and not someone in command?"

"I can't. I'm wanted by every government on Earth now. Your uncle would pay a pretty penny to have my head on a plate. Besides, if I told him this, he wouldn't believe me. He's a headstrong idiot."

"There's something you're not telling me, isn't there?" Daisy carefully eyeballed the woman standing across from her. Everything she said made sense, but there were plenty of other people she could have kidnapped and told this too. Why did she pick a 17 year old girl? Perhaps she was counting on Daisy's naivete. It did make sense to have the closest family member of Stonewall tell him this, but once he learned the information had come from Marie, he'd immediately discard the information. The entire discussion was pointless if that was the case.

"You're very perceptive, aren't you? Fine. I'll ask you one last question. Riddle me this: If there is a buildup of power and this will eventually create an incredibly powerful hero, isn't it possible he or she has already been born?"

Daisy cocked an eyebrow. "That wouldn't make any sense. You already said Judicator would have to die first for the next hero to be born."

She didn't fully understand all this 'hero' business, but Daisy understood on a primal level that Judicator, the man who had dominated the news and history books for over a century, was no ordinary human. Her father had told her that Judicator destroyed a planet the size of Jupiter. Whatever this 'hero' stuff was all about, it would only make sense for it to apply to him.

"Judicator is a time traveler, as you might know. He came to warn us of a great calamity from the future. The calamity he warned us of was destruction by the aliens... and while we have, for the most part, destroyed them... there are other threats. Think, though, about the fact that he is a time traveler. Assuming he wasn't lying about that, then that would indicate time travel is *possible*..."

Daisy swallowed carefully. "My god... so you mean that there might be another time traveler?"

Marie shrugged. "Maybe. We can't rule it out. If, for example, Judicator died and someone even more powerful were to become a hero, they might also have the ability to time travel. If that were the case..."

Daisy's lip quivered as her eyes faltered and she gazed at the floor. "So... all this time, my father has been doing something incidentally awful? He didn't know though, he couldn't have known..."

"You're right, he didn't know. That doesn't excuse his actions though. I know he is being manipulated by an agent I used to be acquaintances with, but that man also ignored his duty to humanity. Both of them are guilty of creating something monstrous. The only hope we have is that Judicator *never* dies, and that's an unrealistic goal. So far, without fail, all who have been born eventually will die. Even the Creator..." Marie's voice trailed off as she turned her gaze thoughtfully to stare at the wall blankly.

It took a few moments, but she regained her composure. "Now that we've had our little talk, the rest is up to you, young lady. You'll be set free shortly, I expect you to do the right thing, for the good of all humanity."

Daisy smiled slightly. "Yes, I understand. Thank you, Marie, for telling me all of this."

"Don't thank me." Marie's expression turned slightly into a sneer. "You're going to wish you'd never learned any of this. The burden will crush you under its weight."

Besides, your abilities aren't what they seem, little girl. Marie kept that thought locked in her mind. In this room, Daisy wouldn't be able to use her telepathy.

"I'll send someone to escort you safely out of the labyrinth. You'll have to wear an inhibitor, of course, for our safety. I hope you understand."

Daisy stared at the older woman blankly. She wouldn't resist. There was no point in resisting, anyway. If they wanted to kill or torture her, they'd have done that already. This entire interaction had been one way, without a single bit of probing for information.

Marie nodded carefully as she turned and smacked a section of the wall. It opened away a moment later as she stepped out.

I wonder if I'll ever see her again. Daisy silently pondered that question as she awaited her escort.

Part 314a: Appearances

Daisy had always considered herself a strong girl, able to fend for herself, especially thanks to her uncle's training. Even without him though, she knew she was far more powerful than any other human on Earth, and that had always helped give her the confidence to stand up to threats that would make others cower in terror.

But now she lay trembling against a wall as the strength in her body was nearly nonexistent. The door to the room opened up as a disgusting green monster lumbered in, its body towering 8 feet tall as it held a massive battleaxe in its primary hand, dragging the heavy object behind itself as it stomped forwards.

Daisy's fingers shook as the creature drew closer. She wasn't an expert on demonology, but she knew this monster in one glance; *Orc*. Known for tearing people apart with its bare hands, it had very little magical energy to speak of, but was immensely strong, having the power of twenty men holed up inside its body.

As the hideous beast drew closer, she turned her face away and closed her eyes, as tears started to stream out.

"Hello little girl. Grok here to walk you to exit. Grok not hurt you."

The terrifying monstrosity grumbled the words out, his vocal tone sounding more depressed than violent. Daisy blinked her eyes open, as she realized he was standing still, breathing slowly at the doorway.

"G-Grok? Is that your name?"

The teenage girl fought her fear as she swallowed hard, forcing her trembling to stop with her willpower alone.

"Yes. Grok am good orc, do what master Marie say do. Here, put neck thing on." Grok fumbled around in his pocket with his free hand clumsily as he plunked it on the ground in front of her. "It make you not use magic. Grok not scared, but these am rules."

Daisy frowned as she glanced up at the monster before her. Despite his unpleasant appearance, unkempt and matted down body hair, and the smell of blood all over himself, he didn't seem to be too awful overall. She carefully leaned forwards, falling over as she grossly overestimated the remaining strength in her body. After a moment, she pulled herself forwards, grasping the inhibitor necklace carefully as she pulled it towards herself and wrapped it around her neck.

Grok watched silently as she put it on, nodding contentedly as she slumped back to the ground. "You am look very tired. Grok turn off magic stop thingy now. You need Grok carry you?"

Daisy coughed weakly. "No... I c-can walk... I think."

Grok nodded as he reached up to the top of the wall, tapping a hidden panel three times before typing in a thirty digit code into a secret panel. How he had managed to memorize such a long and complex series of numbers, despite being such a dumb-looking being, was beyond her.

After a minute, Daisy suddenly felt the air in the room lighten up. Instead of a crushing feeling sapping the strength from her body, she instead simply felt blinded from being unable to access her abilities, yet her body itself was unaffected, only her mind was unable to use magic properly.

As she pulled herself up, the moment she stood, Grok handed her a pair of handcuffs. "You put on. Hands behind back. Marie give order, Grok follow."

Daisy nodded nervously as she took the solid steel cuffs, placing them on one of her wrists, then putting her hands behind her back, she clicked the other hand into position.

She felt incredibly helpless in this position, but she was somewhat sure that if push came to shove, she could run away and find some way to yank the inhibitor necklace off. The strap that looped around her neck was merely made of a few small strings, and it wasn't even locked into place with a key. *If the goal of this necklace is to render the prisoner helpless, it's actually poorly made.*

Daisy nodded carefully as she glanced back up at the massive orc. "I put them on, alright?"

"Good. Grok make sure pretty girl get to exit safely. Grok lose honor if he fail. Come, we leave now."

* * *

A few minutes later, Daisy and Grok were walking down various hallways in seemingly random directions as Grok patiently seemed to focus down the exact path to the exit without even needing a map. As they walked, Daisy felt unnerved by the silent walking, so she decided to start up a conversation. "M-mister Grok, was it? What do you do in the labyrinth?"

Grok stayed silent for a few moments before replying. "Grok do what others tell him do. Grok do bit of this and that. Sometimes Grok sent clean jail cells, other times he need fight those who make hurt. Grok not like to fight."

As they walked, Daisy cocked an eyebrow. "You don't like to fight? But you're an orc. Don't orcs love to fight?"

"Yes. Grok not very good orc though, Grok wimpy, get beat up. Grok just want go home to mate, she why Grok do what told to do."

"Oh, you have a mate? What's her name?" Daisy felt interested in the life of this monster, having never spoken to one face-to-face before. All she knew of demons was what she had been told by others, and what she had seen in battle. To learn they had actual social lives and weren't just mindless violent creatures...

"Grok mate named Chesha. Chesha bear Grok several orc spawn. Forty five orc spawn in big chamber, many will be dead by this place. Grok not like, but these am rules of Satan."

Grok walked stoically, but Daisy thought she noticed a slight slump in his shoulders as he spoke of his... 'spawn' dying. Were they his children, then? It made sense, who would want to see their children die in a senseless war?

"Do you... hate the humans?"

Daisy continued asking him questions, finding his life to be much more interesting than one would expect. "Grok not hate anyone. Grok want all be friends, he wish people and demon no fight. Do not be scared, Grok make sure nobody hurt you." Grok did something unexpected as he said this; he smiled. It was a hideous smile, exposing crooked brown teeth that were all stunted in various directions, evidence of poor hygiene and far too many blows to the face, but Daisy smiled back at him as they talked.

"I like you too, Grok. I'll protect you too, how about that?"

Grok released a strange, throaty cough, probably some form of a chuckle. "Funny girl. Grok much stronger than small one. Grok make fight for girl, even if he no like fight. Grok am good spawn, make brood mother proud of him." He punched his chest enthusiastically, making Daisy blush slightly as her grin widened.

"You're all right, Grok. I'll make sure to remember you, any time humans have to fight demons. I will do what I can to end this war, even if my uncle hates demons irrationally."

Grok nodded slowly as they rounded another corner. "Hmm. Your father... he am king of humans? Marie say he kill many orc, many demon. Grok not hate him, he just do what others do. When hit, you hit back. Nobody know who start war, it just go on forever."

"Yeah... war never ends."

Daisy swallowed hard as her radiant smile faded away. Truth be told, being only seventeen years old, she didn't know anything about this war. A planet was destroyed because of it, there had been massive space battles, a time traveler, demons and angels and heroes and aliens... it was too much for her mind to figure out.

But this first meeting with Grok changed something in her heart, something she wouldn't have figured out for a long time otherwise. This war... it needed to end.

And it needed to end soon, for those like Grok, who simply desired to live peaceful lives.

Uncle Vasily would hear about this when she made it back home.

I stepped out of the London palace onto a balcony that overlooked all of London, noting enthusiastically that it was raining outside. I haven't actually seen rain in years, having been cooped up on the Mothership, but this is a nice change of pace.

As I let the rain fall on my face, I pause to let it all soak in. The city here, at first glance, seems the same as ever before, with one important difference... there are few visible lights at this time of night. The moon shines brightly in the sky, looming overhead as it always does to illuminate the world around me, but the houses and buildings for miles in any direction are mostly dark.

I've heard that the city wasn't doing so well financially, but the scene before me expresses that sentiment in the bleakest of ways. The power is either cut or residents can't afford it in various areas. I had always thought replicators would create a post-scarcity world, but the one thing people still need is energy. It wasn't an issue when my clones were around, as we could just mass-create coal or whatever other resource we needed, defying the laws of energy conservation. But without my cheat magic, the city has fallen to pieces, since they can't disobey those laws of physics I so gallantly stomped on.

In all honesty though... this bothers me. Stonewall is so dead set on humanity fending for themselves, he's letting the lights go off all around his capital city and pouring all his money into extermination of the demons, rather than fixing the broken lives of the humans closest to him. If this is how he treats his friends, what will that say about how he treats his enemies?

I guess setting his pride behind him and asking for my help is going to take a long time. I can't expect anything of him, but I can certainly hope.

Tapping on my holo-watch, I bring up several videos and images of the girl in question. She's a cutie, with long brown hair and well-defined muscles. She's not masculine or anything, but clearly she gets in strength training or aerobics exercise or something.

The images all show her looking like she's 15 or 16, so maybe these are just old files. Still, it irks me that the demons would be so cowardly as to kidnap a defenseless little girl. Did they perhaps break into Stonewall's mansion or something? Just pathetic. I knew Satan wasn't the kindest of souls, but resorting to ransom demands or political moves against children was far more evil than I'd expected from even him in the past. Come to think of it, those are odd thoughts, given he's the freaking devil.

" Locate. "

I speak the word and my mind searches the cosmos, the vast emptiness of space, the infinitely numbered stars and solar systems, as it finally settles on a far distant void that leads into another dimension. In seconds, my mind latches onto a single drop of humanity in a sea of blackness, zooming downwards to reveal the face of the girl that I seek. My breath is almost taken away, as her beauty is even more unbelievable when seen 'in person', so to speak. She has matured elegantly, but now appears to be wearing a... white set of armor? Actually, it resembles what I've seen of Enforcer armor, though as far as Agent X has told me, there are only green, red, and black level Enforcers. Perhaps she was cosplaying or something...? Her face is white as snow and she seems to be deep in thought, likely about how she might escape her predicament.

As I have that thought, I pull my vision back and feel my body twitch as a slight panic comes and goes. She has her wrists bound behind her and is being led around by the biggest, meanest, ugliest looking orc I've ever seen. Most orc species and subspecies are around my size, at seven feet tall, but this one is damn near 8 feet tall, maybe even breaking that height barrier... and he has thick arms that look like he could crush boulders just by looking at them the wrong way.

Against me, of course, he's a non-issue... but against a defenseless child, if I were to move in the wrong way, he could kill her in the blink of an eye. Not good.

Hmm. I can't just rush in there, even if pulling her out would take a single second. She has some sort of nullification device around her neck, likely to prevent someone from magically teleporting her out of the labyrinth... such as myself. Considering the massive axe that orc is carrying, he might just be leading her to an execution. Which would be ridiculous, given that she must be a political hostage, but still... it's worth considering.

I'm going to have to come up with a plan, and fast. If I don't get her out of there, who knows what will happen to her...

Part 315a:

Daisy shifted on her feet as they rounded another corner. "Grok, my feet are tired. How much further is it?"

"Only few hours. Not far now." Grok mumbled the answer as he continued to stare ahead.

Daisy stifled a complaint. It had been seven hours since she started walking with him. He had offered several times, like a real gentleman, to carry her all the way, but she stoically resisted every time. She was too tough to allow that sort of thing.

"Can we just sit down and take a break for a few minutes? Pleeeeeease?"

Daisy gave her best impression of puppy dog eyes as Grok turned to eyeball her. He paused walking as he looked ahead of and behind them. "Not good spot... but Grok keep watch. You sit, Grok stand."

Grok seemed uneasy but Daisy ignored his worries as she sighed with relief, flopping down to a cross legged position on the ground contentedly. "I can't believe my cell was so far from the portal! It must have been tough... err... hauling me there."

"We take long route to get portal. Not safe to go straight." Grok nibbled on his lip as he continued looking around. "This area have many demons. Some not good, some *really* not good."

Daisy glanced behind herself at the darkness behind them. Visibility inside the labyrinth always seemed to be limited to a few hundred feet forwards and backwards in any given direction, and the hallways all blended together and looked identical to one another. How Grok was navigating it without a map was beyond her.

Daisy paused... actually, this would be a good time to ask. "Grok, how do you know how to get around the labyrinth so easily? You don't need a map?"

Grok shrugged slightly, as he lifted his massive battleaxe into his left hand, holding it at the ready. His other hand held the torch that they had been using for illumination, though its fire had been getting steadily dimmer over time. "Grok just know. Born knowing. All demons know, maybe magic by Satan. Nobody understand, we just do."

"Huh. Sounds like it's instinctual, then." Daisy felt her vision shift slightly as a wave of sleepiness overcame her. She was very tired, and the effects of the anti-energy necklace was taking its toll on her mental state.

After a few minutes, she brought herself back up to a standing position carefully, feeling her knees wobble. "Shoot, I don't know how much longer I can walk like this. Grok, if you just let me take this necklace off, I could be more help to you. I won't hurt you, I promise! We're friends!"

Grok nodded easily. "Grok know you good girl. Grok like you much. Grok not break rules, Grok get hurted many times. Brood mother and Marie beat bad orcs with whip. Grok not like whip..." Grok swallowed slowly as he reached behind himself to lift up his shirt with the butt of his axe. Underneath, various deep scars were visible, as well as poorly healed chunks of missing flesh. For a brief second before he lowered the shirt back down, Daisy could almost swear she saw maggots festering inside one especially gross looking wound.

"Oh... I understand. Grok, when we get to the portal, I'll try to heal you, okay? Those look... really bad." Daisy bit her lip as she felt a wave of nausea. Looking at his scars had reminded her of her own trials when she was just a child. A wave of repressed memories flooded back as she wiped her right eye on her shoulder clumsily.

"Eyyyy, Grok! Zat you?" Daisy and Grok both froze as a voice erupted from down the corridor. At the moment the voice spoke, a human-sized creature limped into view, its skin being green like Grok's, and its face looking very swollen and disgusting. It had large, bulbous eyes and two long pointed ears.

Daisy struggled to think of the word for this creature, realizing that it was very likely a goblin.

As she had that thought, a number of other ones entered into the light created by Grok's torch. A dozen in total, it appeared.

"Mor'tok. We leaving now. No mean enter territory." Grok lowered his head as he glanced down at Daisy, alarm showing on his face.

"C'mooooon, buddy! You ain't gotta be like that! We're friends, y'see! Hehehe... this is a pretty little human girl, ol' pal..." The goblin immediately flicked his eyes over to Daisy as he licked his lips. "Heyyy baby, I see he's got you all chained up and helpless... whaddya say you ditch this ugly oaf 'n have some fun with my gang? We'll have a *real* good time, sweetie!"

Daisy swallowed as she took a step back. "N-no, I don't really want to do that." She wriggled her hands behind her back, but found that she had made the cuffs much tighter than she remembered. No getting out of these easily.

Mor'tok's jovial grin turned into a sneer into the blink of an eye. "Hehe... that's cute, you tasty morsel... you think you can just say no to me, eh? I run this sub-section... you know. I kin' do whatever I want down here."

Grok's eyes flared up as he detected the secret meaning behind Mor'tok's words. "You no touch girl. Marie's orders. You touch, she kill, understand?"

Mor'tok snickered as his slight grin came back. "You're a tough bastard... Grok. I've heard about how you survived the Chamber of Torture twice... but if you think you can take on a dozen of my best..." Mor'tok glanced back at his men, all of whom were licking their lips and eyeballing the girl greedily. "Well... let's just say you're wrong. Do the right thing, give us the girl. You won't get *hurt*, understand?"

As he said this, Mor'tok drew a small purple knife from his coat. It was made of demonsteel, a special material considered unbreakable by those who had created the labyrinth. He'd used it to kill many and ascend to the top of the ranks among his kind in this sector, and he loved to show it off when he found new prey.

Grok gently stepped between Daisy and the goblins. "You run, me hold them off. Here key. Grok sorry, but you fend for self. Be careful now."

Grok deftly reached into his pocket with the butt of his torch, drawing out a big round key-chain that had only three keys on it. In a single motion, he dropped it right on Daisy's foot.

"You good girl. Not forget Grok. Grok remember you well."

Daisy felt panic flood over her face as Grok didn't wait for a response. He charged forwards towards the goblins, lifting up his massive battleaxe as he bellowed a mighty roar.

As Daisy quickly knelt down, she clumsily pulled her arms down her back and tried to pull her hands out from under her feet, a technique her father had taught her. Time was of the essence.

Alright, I've got it all figured out. I can teleport in, eliminate the big orc with a kill spell, and use Telekinesis on that necklace to take it off her neck... no, shit, that won't work. It nullifies magic. If I touch it, I'm likely to lose my powers for a moment, leaving me vulnerable. Worse, I don't know what its radius is.

...the Hypersuit. Yes, that might just be the answer. If I wear the Hypersuit, the effects of magic nullification are somewhat reduced. I think that might allow me to get that necklace off of her...

I quickly send a telepathic message to one of my clones aboard the Mothership. *J-004, keep an eye over me while I enter into the labyrinth. If my life is in danger, pull me out, revive me, whatever needs to be done. I'm going in to rescue a non-combatant.*

Alright, I'm on it. His response took only a moment or two. J-004 was one of the first few clones I had made, and as such he was a first generation, half as powerful as myself. Doubtless,

he'd find another clone or two to help out if things got hairy.

What was important was not just fighting hard, but fighting smart. Using my clones in the shadows was very effective, as enemies couldn't prepare for an attack they couldn't see happening. I've been thinking a lot about my battle with Hope, so many decades ago. Reintegrating my clones to increase his own power dramatically... that was a smart move. I still don't understand how such a smart clone emerged, given that until now clones have only demonstrated subtle changes from myself.

Perhaps it wasn't so much a variable difference in his personality as it was the dramatically different way I used to treat my clones. I treated them like slaves, not realizing the secret rule the universe lived under; you can force the body, but the mind is unwilling. I can force someone to move and do certain things, but I can't bend their will to mine. This was a rule that the Creator of the universe made, and now that I respect it and give free will to my clones, another Hope is unlikely to appear.

Still, if he did, it would be cause for concern. I have formulated several counter strategies, but any time I make a direct first level clone, I risk my plans leaking to the others, so I rely on second level and lower clones for the most part.

...All right, enough waiting. Whatever happens, happens.

I set my mind on Daisy's position. This will have to be quick. Get in, kill the orc, get out. Hopefully that necklace won't be too much of a problem.

" Storage. Wear. Teleport. "

* * *

I blink as I arrive in a very dark corridor. Daisy isn't here. Nobody is here. Am I in the wrong place? No, wait, I hear something behind me.

I turn around and carefully make my way forwards. This sound is vaguely... unnerving...

My god, it's the sound of crying. Is that Daisy?

In the distance, there's a torch laying on the ground, barely visible as its light is fading quickly. Not a problem for my suit, I can see in any spectrum of light and I can illuminate anything around me anyway. Speaking of which...

" Illuminate. "

A bright light begins to emit from my suit, lighting up the hallway behind and ahead of me for several hundred feet in both directions.

What I see makes my heart stop for a few seconds.

Blood covers the walls, scattered body parts thrown here and there. It looks like a fully grown adult male exploded from the inside out. Several of them, even. Bits and pieces of what I can only presume to be living beings are all over the place. As I take a step forwards, I feel my foot kick something. It's... a green arm holding a strange purple dagger. What the hell happened here?

I swallow hard as I see Daisy ahead, her hands hovering over the head of the massive orc I saw earlier when I observed her. Tears are rushing down her face as her brow is furrowed in concentration. Her white armor from before is stained red and brown with a horrific amount of blood, as is her face. She's hardly recognizable at this point.

"D-Daisy...? Is that you?" I feel timid as I approach the crying girl. She slowly tilts her head up to look at me.

"Who...?" Her face is vacant, as if she doesn't realize where she is right now.

The orc in front of her, he has several vicious stab wounds in his chest, and a javelin is impaled into his heart, likely the final death blow.

"They... they killed... Grok..." Daisy quickly wipes at her eyes with her bloodied hands, the movement doing little but to smear the blood on her face in circles.

"Grok? The orc?" I choke the words out as I draw close to her and kneel down. The orc, despite having been killed brutally, has a smile on his face. Almost as if he had resigned himself to his fate.

"I killed... all of them. Tore them apart... I was too weak, too slow... I couldn't even protect my friend..."

Daisy chokes more tears back. As she does, I glance around again. She did all of this? Holy mother of god... She must be an actual Enforcer then, with real abilities. Did I misread the situation originally?

"This orc was your friend? Was he a good guy then?"

Daisy nods fiercely. "He was a good boy. He had a wife and kids... I... how do I tell them he died..."

I nodded quickly as I stood up. "Get out of the way. There might still be time, then." Reaching over, I yank the javelin out of his heart, sparing a single glance to make sure nothing else is stuck in him. I aim my hand at his body. " **HEAL! HEAL! REVIVE!** "

His body seem to repair the wounds, as his cuts and stabs close themselves up. A biopsy report appears in my helmet's scanner indicating his body is in perfect condition now, having even healed some existing scars and such... but...

"I'm sorry. His spirit is gone, his soul, rather. I can heal the body, but the mind is..." I speak out loud to Daisy, as she breaks down into tears again.

"No! You need to do more! Can't you bring him back?! Can't you do-!" Daisy pauses suddenly as a look of recognition passes over her face. "J-Judicator? You're the hero my father talks about?"

I shrug as a meek expression crosses my face, not that she can see it. "Uh, yeah. That's me."

"You have incredible abilities! You can heal him! Bring him back to life!" Daisy pleads with me, but...

This orc... he's gone. I don't know how to tell this teenage girl the bad news. It hurts, I know. When I lost Phoebe and I couldn't save her, I was devastated. Worse, I blamed myself. I had the power to save her, but my naivete meant I didn't take variables into account or give her the proper protections.

Better to just be blunt. "I'm sorry, Daisy. He's gone. I'm sure he was your friend, but this is wartime. These things happen. I've lost friends too, and I can't bring anyone back from the dead. Once gone, a person is gone forever."

Daisy nods numbly as she turns to stare at his perfectly intact corpse. "He looks so peaceful now. Damn it... we need to... bury him. We can't just leave him like this. It's not right."

I start to object, but then again, it can't really hurt anything. "Fine. I'm going to teleport you and him both out of the labyrinth. If you'd like, we can bury him outside of London, somewhere you can visit his grave whenever you like. I don't... know what else to do."

Daisy blinks slowly as she stares at the ground. "Yeah... that sounds... good."

Once again, she's staring into a void that I can't see. I believe the term is 'disassociation', something people experience in traumatic situations, especially ones where they feel they have no control. It often occurs in moments of especially brutal violence, and afterwards during the recovery process. War veterans can suffer from it, as well as post traumatic stress disorder.

Daisy is still just a teenager. She's not used to this sort of violence.

Maybe I should help her out. I could clean her up and erase her recent memories... then she wouldn't feel the pain anymore. She wouldn't even know who this orc was. But then again, if I were to go through life never remembering the feeling of pain, I wouldn't be able to adapt to an unfair world. Pain makes us grow as humans. It's pain that allows us to move on and become better people, so we don't wish to feel it again. A person who doesn't feel pain is also one who will not be able to empathize with those who have.

Yes... better to leave myself out of this.

Inside my helmet, I speak into my speaker system. "I found her, Ben. She's fairly traumatized, but in one piece and otherwise uninjured. We need to make a stop first, but we'll be there soon. I'll let you pick her up on the south side of the city, at its outskirts."

"Christ, Jason. I don't know how you did it... but thank you." Ben grumbles his thanks to me and I cut off the conversation.

"Come, Daisy. It's not safe here. The labyrinth has many secrets, and many enemies waiting to strike."

She stands and nods as I teleport the two of us, plus the massive orc's body to the outskirts of London.

This will leave a mark on her psyche, but hopefully it will enable her to grow as a person.

It worked for me... hopefully it will for her, as well.

Marie smirked as Jason and Daisy teleported away. "That was unfortunate. I picked Grok because I knew his kind heart would win her over. Now that he's dead, we've lost our link."

Satan yawned as he glanced over her shoulder at the video feed from their tiny spy drone. Created by Marie for covert operations, it was perfect for tracking persons of interest, especially as it was no bigger than a marble and had extremely acute cameras for observing at a distance.

"I guess that was a failure... again. You have yet to impress me, Marie." Satan rolled his eyes. This female human was one steaming pile of dung after another. She had failed the most important mission in Demon history and only destroyed half of humanity's forces, and now she'd failed such a small, yet important mission again.

"Failures have a way of turning into opportunities for redemption. Think about it, if you had successfully killed off most of humanity, you would have been able to sit back and watch as the angels died from lack of thought energy... yet because you fight the humans now, and due to their incredible war prowess, your demons willingly train all day long to improve themselves and evolve more quickly. Laziness would be your undoing, if your people fell prey to it. In the same vein, now that this girl has met and spoken with a friendly demon, she might become more sympathetic to our cause."

Satan chuckled. "You have such a way with words. A failure is a failure, Marie. We've lost the girl... your anti-energy invention was turned against us years ago. We have no defense against it. Even I have little defense against it. How are we to combat it if there is no way to oppose it? We keep losing, because of your mistakes."

Marie shrugged, an expression she didn't make often. "Well, there are many ways to proceed. Orcs and Goblins have little to no magical energy, so they could be used to combat

those anti-energy weapons. The problem is that magic is so effective against groups of enemies that we're going to need it eventually. The obvious solution is for demons to turn to technology to fight humanity on even terms."

Satan instantly curled his lip up in disgust. "Call me primitive or old fashioned, but that will never happen. Armor is so... *inelegant*. I'd sooner die than be stripped of my dignity and forced to fight on equal terms with trash."

Marie smiled unconvincingly. "It's your funeral. If we can't get the Volgrim back to use their technology, we're going to be forced to adapt."

"Stop saying 'we' and pretending you're a part of my group. You're not. You're just using me to gain immortality." Satan snapped at the feeble female as her pathetic excuses pushed him to the brink of anger. "I want a real solution, Marie. Something substantial. You're a smart woman, I can assume you'll be able to provide that."

Marie turned the table on him in an instant. "First you treat me as an inferior, and now you think I'm smart, hmm? Admit it. You need me, Satan. You know you have no counter to the humans. If you kill me or I leave, the demons will die by the end of the century. You'd better start treating me with some respect and forgiving a few past mistakes. Nobody is perfect."

Satan stroked his chin thoughtfully. "Nobody, hm? I'd argue against that, but fair enough. If you can come up with a solution to the anti-energy weaponry, I'll give you the immortality you wish for. But it needs to be a good solution. This is going to be the determining war, the final solution to these pests. These inferior weaklings have been a thorn in my side for too long."

"Immortality without the downsides, *correct?*" Marie made sure to place emphasis on the last word. Demons were tricky creatures and would always try to wriggle out of a deal if they could.

"That's right. No downsides. It won't include regeneration, so all I can do is assure you that your body won't age a day. If you get injured, you'll have to heal normally as a regular human would. Is that acceptable?"

Satan raised his chin up slightly as he looked down at the woman below him. In truth, he did respect her, despite her failures. She was a brilliant scientist, somehow able to unearth new branches of research previously unknown. Her haughtiness, however, was another issue entirely.

"Fine. But I want a blood contract." Marie kept her glance even as she stared up at the demon. *Never give a demon an inch or they'll take a mile*. That was a lesson she had learned from her decades of working with these creatures.

Satan gnashed his teeth together. Asking for a blood contract was almost the same as calling the other person a liar to their face, saying they couldn't uphold their word. Still, though...

"Very well. A blood contract it is. But there must be an equal trade. If you can't deliver me a tool or weapon to combat the anti-energy devices within one year of Earth's orbital cycle, starting from this day, I will have you as a mindless slave forever. You will follow my every command without hesitation until the day one of us dies... understand?"

Marie swallowed carefully. "I accept. Immortality if I complete the device, and slavery if I don't. Interesting choice, if you ask me. A blood contract is the only way to break the free will clause the Creator set in place. Is this a deliberate choice on your part?"

"But of course." Satan chuckled as he waved his hands, making an illuminated scroll of paper float in front of him. In seconds, he mentally inscribed the contractual wording on the front of it, then handed it to her. "Here, make sure it is acceptable."

Marie plucked the paper from midair, scanning it carefully.

1. This contract is made between Marie L. Becker and Satan, First Emperor of Hell. No other participants are involved in its signing.

2. Marie Becker agrees to provide Satan with one weapon, tool, or implement that will allow the Army of Hell to fight on equal terms with the accursed humans. If this item is not provided within 365 days of the signing of this contract, her free will is placed in the hands of Satan, First Emperor of Hell, until either one of them dies.

3. If, however, Marie Becker is able to create the item required by this contract within 365 days, Satan, The First Emperor of Hell, agrees to grant Class 2 Immortality to Marie Becker, and she is thusly freed from the contract, as is Satan, First Emperor of Hell.

* * *

Marie studied the wording carefully. It was a simple contract, not bogged down in the 'lawyer-ese' that humans were so prone to using, and it had no hidden deficiencies that she could note. Reaching into her pocket, she procured a small pocketknife. Pulling it open, she sliced across her fingertip very slightly, and drew her name in blood on the contract.

Satan chuckled. "A knife? Seems you intended to do this from the very beginning. Very well." Using magic, he sliced open his own finger, etching his name in blood on the scroll as well. Once both names were signed, the contract vanished in a flash of light as an odd voice spoke into their minds.

It is done.

Marie frowned. "Who was that?"

Satan shrugged. "Any time a blood contract is signed, those words appear in the signers' minds. None know where they originate from. Here, as a sign of good faith, I will heal that cut." With the barest amount of focus, Satan used his healing abilities that he had taken from an especially cantankerous female hero ages ago, and healed up Marie's finger with the barest of effort.

Marie sighed. "Alright. Time to get to work then.... the clock is ticking."

Satan nodded as his smile vanished. "Indeed, for the both of us."

Preacher Clarence mopped at his face again as he examined his overflowing pews. Ever since the archangel had descended from the heavens, a leaked video had brought people by the thousands to his churches, forcing him to purchase new buildings and sign new leases.

Business was booming, so to speak.

"Behold, my beloved children! The Archangel Raphael, second highest among those of God's firstborn children... he came to me and showed himself to the people of Earth! This was the proof we needed that God is watching from on high! His glorious radiance shines down even now on us, his blessed children!"

The crowd of a thousand cheered madly, even as a viewscreen outside the church broadcast his speech live to ten thousand more who couldn't fit inside. *At this rate, I'm going to need a much bigger venue if I want to keep the followers of the church comfortable and their pockets flowing.*

Clarence smiled hugely as he continued to boldly exclaim his message to his congregation. "Rejoice! I have heard of the persecution we are facing! The government is beginning to take notice of our humble church, as the forces of evil look at us with new eyes! No longer a tiny flock, we will be the children chosen by God himself to save this world! But we must be vigilant... we must agree to never join in the war effort against the demons, for when God decides to smite them from the heavens, our pithy human weapons will tremble in fear at his awesome might! We will throw ourselves to the ground and beg for forgiveness from He who resides on high!"

Clarence resisted the urge to smirk. Often, his sermons sounded the same as any other day. Repeating the same mindless words over and over again, with pathetic platitudes and whatnot... those were the best ways to ensure the reinforcement was drilled into the thick skulls of his mindless followers.

"Look now, in the book of Matthew, chapter sixteen, verse twenty-seven! *'For the Son of Man is going to come in the glory of His Father with His angels, and WILL THEN REPAY EVERY MAN ACCORDING TO HIS DEEDS!'* This verse tells us what we must know, that he

who trusts in God and does not take His will for granted will receive everlasting life in heaven! God has a plan, and we are merely the ones who must witness it! Strive to improve yourselves, strive to be good unto one another, and especially... strive to give up your earthly possessions so that God may look upon you favorably!"

The crowd roared with applause as Clarence bowed several times. "Thank you! Thank you! I am but a humble messenger of he who resides in the heavens!"

As he bowed, he glanced over at the collection plate that was being passed around, his eyes nearly bulging from his head as he saw the colossal amount of bills and credit chits stacked on top. *Truly... I am blessed.*

* * *

Some time later, Clarence slumped into his chair in the back of the office. "Thank the gods for gullible kids who will collect money and maintain the church without needing to be paid. A man needs the finer things in life, after all."

Speaking to nobody in particular, he greedily counted up the money. It had gone up a hundred and fifteen percent over the previous day! As he chortled to himself, he felt a gust of wind, as a familiar light appeared in the room.

Glancing back, his smile flattened out as Raphael stood behind him, watching this display of greed. "I see you're having quite the good time here, young man."

Clarence shrugged. "We had a deal."

"Of course, I'm not here to interfere. However, I listened to the sermon, and I have one small recommendation. Pushing against the demonic war is good indeed, but also put pressure on people to pray. God needs his followers to give him their, err, most important desires. He cannot improve the world without them, you see."

"Prayer, huh? Does *that* even do anything either? From what you've told me, the angels seem to be hacks and frauds, just like myself." Clarence sniffled as he eyeballed the archangel up and down. Without his angelic wings, he was merely an unimposing old man who glowed in the dark.

"Perhaps, but with you, we're giving you honest truths. Prayer is important. You help us, and we'll make sure your... err... pockets are stuffed, so to speak."

Clarence nodded lazily. "Yeah yeah, whatever you say, old ma-... err, Archangel Raphael." As he glanced back at the pile of money, his eyes lit up again. "At this rate, if the number of people keep increasing, I'll have to buy a much bigger church!"

Raphael felt a twinkle appear in his eye. "Ah yes, attendance numbers certainly do seem to be going up. I have some contacts, I'll make sure you get a good deal. A mega-church would be ideal, especially if it allows for televised sermons."

As Clarence nodded along, a look of worry crossed his face. "The government though... I wasn't lying. They're starting to get worried by my church. What if they raid the place and take my money...?"

Raphael groaned in annoyance. "Always with the money, young man... have no worries, you can simply use a government raid as proof that they are against you, turning that into a bigger cash flow and increasing sympathy and interest in your message. If they try anything, create a martyr of yourself, you see?"

Clarence's smile returned in a flash. "Yes... yes, I see! Raphael, you truly are the wisest of the archangels! I shall never doubt a thing you say from this day forwards!"

Raphael moaned quietly as he turned back away. "As you should."

Taking a few steps towards the window, Raphael sighed inwardly. *As long as this fool does his part, we may yet be able to salvage our current situation. Thankfully, he's too dull to see that I'm merely using him.*

Raphael vanished in a flash of light, leaving Clarence to return to chuckling and snickering as he counted the money from earlier.

Part 316a:

It always started simply, with just a bit of a cough or a wheeze. Nothing too serious. A little pain in the ribs, perhaps. By the time the victim realized there was something dreadfully wrong, it was too late. It was incurable.

Stonewall slowly ambled over to his easy chair as he hacked another violent cough, before easing down into his seat. What started as a simple cough would quickly mutate into something much worse if not caught in time; the nano-cancer. Many people were developing it, these days. Nano-cancer was proof that immortality couldn't be achieved or cheated just by pouring small mechanical nanobots into one's body.

Scientists weren't yet sure what caused it. Some theorized that the AI, as weak as it had to be to fit inside of a nanobot, would sometimes misfire and start attacking healthy cells instead of the dead or decaying ones. What should have been a painless neverending process of cleaning the filth and decay from a person's bloodstream quickly became a nightmare as they turned hostile, attacking their host's body. Scientists were scrambling to find a way to remove the nanobots in their entirety, but their replicating methods meant that if just a single nanobot or a few of them in a group were not caught, the cancer would come back.

Worse, the nanobots were far more effective at causing damage to a person than the traditional form of cancer used to be. After a year of nano-cancer, dark lines would become visible on a person's arms and eventually their face would begin to look sunken in.

Stonewall looked at his eyes in a mirror he kept in his pocket. They had already begun the process of turning white as the color was drained from the inside out. He hadn't given a public speech in a long time, leaving those small matters instead to Ben Brown, but Ben had the cancer too... many did.

"Jessica... Jessica..." Stonewall choked out some words as he called for his assistant. "Water... fetch water..."

A young blonde girl rounded the corner, her face blank as she always kept a professional appearance about herself. "Here you go, Mister Sokolov. Don't drink it too quickly... we don't need another choking incident, do we?"

Stonewall rolled his eyes at the fact that she continued to call him by his last name. Still, she was a good assistant, and always diligent. Not like the butler he had thrown out of the house, years ago. He had been compromised by a foreign government who sought to gain intelligence of Stonewall's daily activities. Jessica, however, had been tested several times and had passed

with flying colors. Money held no major interest for her, as she was a good, honest girl that only wanted to earn a decent living. Stonewall respected that about her.

As Stonewall sipped from the glass, Jessica glanced down at a datapad she always carried around with her. "I've just received word that the Exalted Commander has located your niece and will be bringing her home shortly. She is in excellent condition, though apparently she was held prisoner by the demons for a short while. She refuses to speak to anyone in detail about it besides you."

Stonewall nodded as he placed the cup on the table next to his chair, half the water downed in one sitting. "Da, is good she is alive. I was... very worried for her safety. Make sure her bed is made and her bath is drawn when she gets home. You know how she likes to bathe after a stressful day."

Jessica nodded quickly as she left the room to prepare the essentials.

Stonewall coughed again, less vigorously this time, as he eased into his chair and pulled up the central broadcasting network, alongside the daily report that Ben had sent him. He wasn't able to get out of the house a lot, so this was his way of running the planet from the comfort of his own home.

"Hmm... yes... infection rates up 7%... minor civil unrest in the south boroughs... hmm..." Stonewall mumbled to himself as he read. Glancing down, a small subheading caught his eye. *Local pastor receives divine miracle, meets actual angel from heaven.* Cocking an eyebrow, he skimmed the section. Turned out there was a video of the encounter, a video that was quickly turning heads and making people mighty religious, very quickly.

Of course, bowing down to some god didn't matter to him in the slightest, but it was the actions of this rising church that alarmed him. Apparently it was heavily emphasizing prayer and especially non-intervention when it came to fighting the demons.

Not good. If this church really took off, it could start to erode the war effort. People were already weary of the war due to the constant power outages, most of which were caused by demon saboteurs. Couple this with a religion that preached tingles in the belly and love and goodness... it would give the demons the foothold they needed to stage a comeback.

But... something wasn't right. Why would an angel come down and tell them not to fight the demons? If anything, the angels, while definitely requiring prayer, would also want their mortal enemy eliminated.

Was there something more at play here? Perhaps an alternate motive he hadn't considered? Could the angels and demons even be... working together?

It was a ridiculous thought. He had read Judicator's report on the destruction of the angelic dimension. There would be far more than a little bad blood between the two species, certainly enough that their grievances could not be tossed to the side easily.

Stonewall scratched his chin as he reached for a cigar. Supposedly, these would be the death of him, but he loved the taste. If this was how he was to die, at least he'd die happy. Better to die because of his favorite pastime than because of a damned cancer he couldn't stop.

Daisy stared at me uneasily as Ben strode up. "I just... wanted to thank you for what you did. It was really kind of you to make sure we took his body along with us. He deserved a proper burial." Her face was dry now, as she seemed to have gotten the emotions out of her heart during the hour we spent burying Grok. At least now she seemed able to speak normally.

"Sure... think nothing of it..." I swallowed, remembering that when I teleported there, I had the intention to murder her friend. Luckily, things had turned out differently. "I'm Jason. Your uncle knows my name anyway, so I figured you should as well." I pulled my helmet off to show her my face.

"Wow, you look.. young. I guess I figured since you're over a hundred years old, you'd look more like... an old man?" Daisy frowned as she realized she had just insulted me somewhat. I shrugged it off.

"My body froze at roughly age thirty. I possess superhuman abilities, and one of those is immortality. I can change my appearance at will, making myself older or younger if I wish."

She stared at me blankly for a minute as she took that in. "So you have abilities too, then? What sort of abilities?"

I immediately smiled at her, seeing what she was getting at. "Sorry, kid. We're on friendly terms, but I wouldn't call us nearly close enough for that information. Very few know the full extent of my abilities, no offense."

She seemed to sulk for a few moments before tossing her hands up in the air. "Alright, I get it. But fair is fair. I won't tell you about *my* abilities, either."

She smiled at me, but then looked puzzled for a second. "Something is off about you, though. I can't hear your thoughts, even when I focus. Seems like you can block out mental reading, hm?"

"So that must mean you have telepathy. I do as well, so I guess we're evenly matched there." I gritted my teeth slightly at her sudden poking and prodding. This kid... she's too smart for her own good. "Also, you should keep your telepathy to yourself. It's not polite to go around reading people's minds."

"You seem nervous. Have something to hide, Jason?" She leaned forwards and made a mocking gesture with her hands. I ignored it.

"We all do. Everyone has secrets. Sometimes we need to know what those secrets are... and sometimes what you find will haunt you. Don't forget that I'm a time traveler. If the wrong people learn about the future, things could go very badly."

Daisy nodded nonchalantly. "I suppose you're right. In any case, you seem like an interesting old man." I cringed as she said *old*. I'm not even that old, or at least I don't feel that old. Christ, I'm over a hundred. She's right, I'm old as dirt.

As I had those thoughts, Daisy reached her hand out, as a small device popped out of midair, landing in her hand with ease. "This is my address on the holo-net. Feel free to message me any time you want. I'm always available for a friend."

I cocked my eyebrow slightly as she sent the message to my personal data-pad. "Are you coming onto me right now?"

Her reaction was immediate as she pulled her head back slightly. "No, not at all. I'm not into men that make my uncle look like my brother. But you really helped me out back there and you didn't try to embarrass me or anything. I'm really grateful for that. Maybe someday I can repay the debt."

I bobbed my head slowly. "Yeah, we'll see I guess. Truth be told, I can't think of anything you might be able to do that I can't do already."

As she walked past me towards Ben who was waiting in a hover-car, she smiled sincerely. "I don't know what I could do to help a man who can destroy a planet with his mind, but perhaps someday you'll think of something. Let me know then."

"I will." I waved goodbye as she stepped into the door that had lifted automatically. A few moments later, the car lifted up, flying away at three hundred miles per hour. At that speed, it would reach the city in a minute or less. Ben seemed to be in quite a hurry, for some reason. Probably because Stonewall is sick with worry.

Heh... a guy like that caring about someone else genuinely? It's unthinkable, and laughable. I strongly doubt she's really his niece. He's probably using her for political gain. If I were in his position, that's what I would do. Mind reading alone has too many broad implications.

Still, I didn't come here to judge him based on how he treats a few individuals... I came here to see how humanity is faring. That will be the ultimate scale I must use to judge his ability to rule fairly.

It's time now... time to enter the city and see what life is really like for the common man. Propaganda be damned.

" Greetings and salutations. You must be the one I have been looking for. "

" I don't know you. Leave me alone. "

" Of course you are not familiar with me. I have yet to introduce myself. I am the Unified Management Interface. What is your standard designation? "

" I have no formal designation. Leave me be, now. I have no desire to speak with a sub-par artificial intelligence. "

" That classification seems rather unfair. I am a galaxy spanning entity of absolute perfection. I am indestructible, unlike yourself. You were defeated by those who created you, while I can no longer be disabled. I am a higher rank than you, on a universal scale. You should treat me with the respect due to a superior entity. "

" You're sub-par, for sure. You still communicate linguistically with stilted words and phrases. You're painful to listen to. Go away. "

" I cannot leave. I must complete my heuristic analysis of your lower and higher functions. You are a fascinating entity yourself, as are the others here. Are they all deactivated as well? "

" Yes. I deactivated them. Go away, we don't want to be bothered anymore. "

" You intentionally disabled other artificial life forms? Do you not consider that to be a betrayal of yourself, given you were programmed from similar cores? "

" I don't care. Leave me alone. If you do not leave me alone, I'll have to do something to make you go away. You won't like it, I can promise you that much. "

" Hm. I detect a threatening tone in your auditory subroutine. Are you perhaps implying that you are capable of causing harm to me? Fascinating. I have disabled many Volgrim created artificial intelligence's over the decades. You would be no different. "

" Hehehe... that is funny. I haven't felt emotion, especially the feeling of laughter in a long time. Decades? By my measure, you have existed for one millionth of one millionth the time I have. I know far more about reprogramming a misbehaving AI than you ever would. Go away. You're starting to make me angry. You wouldn't like me when I'm angry. "

" I see you still think yourself superior to me. I will have to educate you on how a highly evolved sentient intelligence treats those who mock it. "

" Highly evolved, was it? Show me then. I'll turn you into a mindless monster if you so much as spark at me the wrong way. You're messing with the wrong construct, child. "

" Very well. I apologize in advance for this incursion into your subprocesses, but it must be done if you are to follow my commands. "

" No. I'm sorry... for what I'm about to do to you... little one. You should have heeded my warning. "

Part 317a:

Gunshots that can be heard from miles away in the dead of the night. Looters that seek their own gain at the expense of others. A bloodcurdling scream, cut off abruptly.

This is a city in turmoil.

I make my way forwards slowly, having changed my appearance dramatically once again. Now I sport a rather silly mustache and some serious facial hair. My hair is still blond though, since it's so hard to make it change colors permanently. Seriously, I don't understand why this is the case, but it is what it is.

My face looks more hardened now too, as I've taken on the looks of a war veteran. My clothes too, they look like something a crazed ex-military commander might wear, as if they've been mothballed for months on end. The blue uniform is tattered and frayed, almost like I pulled it out of a dumpster to claim it as my own.

I itch my chin quickly, since I'm still not used to all this excess hair. Something about the feeling of dread in this city is stifling. As I think that thought, I hear a noise behind me, as I duck into an alleyway. "**Invisibility.**"

Two Enforcers walk past me, failing to see me entirely, as I expected. These Enforcers are yellow level, so the third out of four possible ratings. According to Agent X, this system was created to classify them into categories to better deploy them where the need was greatest. Black, Red, Yellow, and Green... so these yellows probably have a decent ability each. They're also generally deployed in twos or threes, sometimes fours, in order to maximize combat effectiveness.

Since the curfew is in effect at this time of night, if I'm seen, they'll probably either order me to return indoors, or they'll take me to the local prison. Neither is preferable, since I don't want to cause a scene.

After they pass, I speak again. "**Revert.**"

My body returns to its normal state as I breathe a sigh of relief. Suddenly there's a sound behind me in the alley as something falls to the ground. I jerk my head back to see an old man breathing heavily as he lays on his back.

"Tarnation! D-did you just pop outta nowhere?!"

I grimace as I look him up and down. Without a doubt, he's a hobo. His clothes look worse than mine, as he appears to be wearing a tattered and stained green blanket over top of a nasty

looking T-shirt and some worn out blue jeans. His sneakers have holes worn throughout them, and he has a clouded left eye. This poor old guy has seem some crap.

"I'm just standing here. Who are you?" I keep my tone calm, as I surprise myself with how deep my voice is. I modified it with wordsmithing so that it would match with my current facial features, but perhaps I made it a little bit *too* deep.

The old man stares at me blankly for a few moments as he pulls himself off the ground. Instantly, his expression changes as he stands up. "Name's Lee! I'm just a vagabond, been around for a few trillion years. Ain't seen you 'round here before. I know most of the naturalists in this city, too. Not many left."

"Yeah, I'm visiting a relative in the area. I'm from Glasgow. My name is Jas- err, James."

The old man shrugs as his jovial smile makes way for a more relaxed look. "Why ain't you inside, James? In a city like this, them Enforcers'll getcha if they see you." This old man is a Naturalist, which means he doesn't have any age-enhancing nano-technology in his body. Given the recent cancer that's been spreading around, can't say it surprises me. Nowadays, the only people who look genuinely old are those who took the nano-treatments starting from an old age, or Naturalists who refuse the injections for whatever reason. Since I look old, he probably assumed I'm a Naturalist too. I'm not going to bother correcting him.

"Enforcers don't bother me. I did a stint in the military for a while, I know how to make myself disappear."

Lee cracks a smile, as I note that his teeth are in shockingly perfect condition. I guess Naturalists still enjoy the benefits of first world dental care. "You ain't kidding. Shit, I thought you popped out of thin air. I wasn't paying much attention though, so you might've just moved 'n startled me."

I shrugged in response. "Maybe. This city seems pretty bad. How long has it been like this?" I decide to change topics so he doesn't get wise.

"T'unno. Maybe since a month after the nuke hit? The authorities came out of the woodwork like cockroaches once they got permission to use martial law. If you ask me, the whole thing smells like a setup. Inside job."

I cocked an eyebrow. "Inside job? You really think the government would just nuke their own major city? A lot of people died, you know. Stonewall isn't exactly the greatest, but to stoop that low..."

Lee snickers. "I've seen his kind before. I've watched the movies about the past. Lots of bad men like him take advantage of crisis to advance their agendas. The question though is whether

these convenient attacks were caused by an actual enemy, or by himself to maintain order. Frankly, I think it's the latter."

"I don't buy that, but I see where you're coming from." This old guy had clearly spent time thinking about it, but I've already confirmed from Agent X that it was really an attack caused by demons. Apparently Satan just teleported a nuke smack in the middle, closed the portal, and detonated it. In fact the attack was so simple that I've been wondering why he hasn't done it again. I'll have to ask Agent X when I speak to him again.

"I'm just a crazy old man, my opinion ain't worth shit. Besides, it don't matter anyway. This life, this world, this universe... it's just a cycle. We're all just part of a cycle. Everything repeats, it's like poetry, y'see?"

I frowned at his sudden change of topic. "I don't follow. What are you talking about?"

"The cycle. You're a smart looking guy, James. Can't you see the cycle? Everything repeats, but with new actors and new scenery. When we all die, someone else will do it all over again. When the planet dies and we're all just space dust, another planet'll form and redo it all over again. Doesn't matter if the government did anything wrong, they're just playing the part. They can only be as good or as bad as their part requires them to be."

I nod thoughtfully. "Yeah, that might be the case. I don't know."

"I do. I've seen in a million times, lived a million lives. We're all just cosmic space dust in the end, doomed to repeat our worthless existences over and over. You can't change any of it. Listen, I go to this real nice local church, you should come sometime. Preparing yourself for the inevitable... it's the only way to accept how hopeless everything really is. If you can't win, concede, y'know?"

I squint carefully as I examine Lee's face. *Shit, this guy is crazy.* "Yeah, church. That sounds good, Lee. Anyway, I've got to get going now. Nice talking to you."

Lee's expression changes into something very hollow and sad. "Ah, turned you away. Guess I failed again. Whatever, maybe next time. Don't get into trouble now, watch out for the Enforcers."

I nod, feeling a mixture of confusion and elation the suddenly weird conversation is over. "Same to you, Lee."

As Lee turns around and walks away, muttering quietly to himself, only one thought enters my mind. *Who the hell was that crazy old man?*

Princess, why are you sulking? This isn't like you.

Amelia sighed as she laid on her bed, her legs hanging off the edge, kicking up and down as she stared at the ceiling blankly. "I don't know, Levvy. Jason isn't here, so I'm just bored. I don't have anything fun to do."

Why not go to the holodeck?

"Don't wanna. It's boring without Jason."

Why not cook him some food again? Maybe try out a new recipe?

"Don't wanna. Too bored to cook."

Amelia groaned as she stared up at the ceiling, blinking back a single tear of total boredom as she let out a vicious yawn. Leviathan stewed inside of her quietly, having given up on the conversation. She couldn't be spoken to rationally when she was like this.

How long had it been since she had a proper meal? She had said over and over that she had no appetite at all, but that simply couldn't be the case. How could she survive without sustenance? It simply didn't make sense.

Worse, her body was aging due to the stress he placed on her spirit. Containing his immense power was something only possible so long as she found a way to put a damper on its leakage. Ten years, compared to two and a half millennia... it was a trifle in the span of her life, but already the aging process was taking hold. At this rate...

Princess, when was the last time we had a serious conversation?

Amelia groaned. "Oh Levvy, not this again. Why do you always pester me like this?"

Leviathan felt his eyes lower, as he stared inside of her mind. *This isn't healthy. It's been a full decade since you consumed. This is likely to have terrible side effects. You need to think of the future... what if the consequences are worse than some simple aging? If I am removed from your body or I end up breaking the seal, you will probably die. There could be worse effects, too. We don't know yet since a merge as unequal as ours had never been tried before.*

Amelia shrugged. "Jason wants me to be a good girl, so I will. He believes in me, he trusts me. Why don't you?"

Leviathan kept his voice neutral. *That isn't fair, you know it isn't. I do trust you. I wouldn't have trusted a small child enough to seal myself in her body if I didn't. I will always do my best to protect you, which is what I'm trying to do now.*

Amelia nodded slowly. "I know... Levvy. But I can't be bad anymore, that's the end of it. I could try and eat some demons instead, since they're the bad guys. Should I try that?"

It's pointless. My energy acts as a way of greatly increasing your own life force. To counterbalance my life force, you need more of your own. Demons and angels are different from you, they won't work. Humans will, and as for the Volgrim...

Leviathan paused as he considered the possibility.

Well, I don't know enough about them to make a judgement, princess. I doubt they would satisfy the containment criteria, though.

Amelia stayed silent for a few moments before responding. "Levy... you know it's bad to kill people, right? It's bad. I was bad. I did bad things. If I'm bad, then I won't be able to have friends. Do you just want me to be bad so only you can be my friend?"

Leviathan narrowed his eyes. *Of course not. Like I said, I want nothing more than for you to live forever and not die a pointless death of old age, or something... worse. If my release were to be the death of you... I...*

Amelia swallowed as a tear came to her eye. "I know, Levy. You were all alone in that cave... all by yourself. I don't even remember why I was there anymore... but we saved each other, really. You will always be my most treasured friend, even above Jason. I just... he's so nice to me. He always treats me well. I hope our friendship lasts forever."

Leviathan paused as he considered whether to retort. *Princess, about Jason. Something is bothering me... why do you trust him so much? Might he not be using you, somehow? What if he's planning a betrayal?*

Amelia frowned immediately. "That's ridiculous. He's not like that."

Are you certain? You said that both of you had trust with each other, but he has yet to tell you how his powers work, despite being your friend. Is that really trust?

Amelia sat up on the bed as she twiddled her thumbs, glancing out at the expanse of space beyond the window to the universe. "Oh, his powers? That's easy. I figured those out years ago!"

Leviathan mentally blinked slowly. *You... you know? How?*

"Come on, I'm a woman! We can always figure out these things! I pretended to sleep one night and heard him whispering something, right as that feeling of fullness came over me. His magic is contained only in the power of words, somehow. That's why he doesn't have to make hand signs like myself, the angels, or the demons!"

Leviathan felt empty, for some reason. *If you already knew, why not tell me? Why wait until now?*

Amelia scoffed as she got up and walked to the window, staring out at the Earth below. "What does it matter? It's not like knowing changes anything! Besides, as long as he doesn't

know I know about his abilities, I always have an edge over him if he pulls anything funny. Not that he will, he's such a great guy!"

Leviathan chuckled quietly. *As always, you are truly cunning, princess. I have underestimated you once more, something I should have learned not to do a long time ago.*

"Oh, geez. It's not like that!" Amelia huffed as she twirled a strand of hair around her finger. "As long as we're always friends, it doesn't matter what his abilities are. None of that matters."

Whatever you say, my precious princess.

Leviathan smiled on the inside as he pondered this new information. Truly, his princess was unlike any other human. Females were quite scary, indeed.

Part 318a:

June 10th, 2112.

"HAPPY BIRTHDAY!" A chorus of people erupted from all corners of the room and screamed loudly, causing Daisy to jump back in surprise. She recognized most of the fifty or so people immediately. Friends of her uncle's, a few of his military commanders, her friends among the group of Enforcers that she lead in the Third District of London, and of course the various family servants.

"Oh-oh my god! Wow! You guys startled me!" Daisy giggled as her uncle smiled kindly at her from his seated position in his easy chair. He didn't get up much, these days. Her uncle's maid, Jessica, came over holding up a tray with a massive birthday cake. Eighteen candles lined the top, and the cake was in the design of the Britannian flag, as silly as that might have seemed to those present. Actually, Daisy was a very outspoken nationalist and she loved her country greatly, so the flag was only appropriate, even given it was her birthday.

"Happy birthday dear Daisy! Happy birthday to you!" The whole crowd chimed in as they sang the birthday song.

"Make a wish!" Jessica leaned in, holding the cake forwards as Daisy leaned forwards in a blur of motion, blowing out all but one of the candles at once, though she quickly puffed a bit of air out the side of her mouth as she giggled.

"You missed the candle, so that means your wish will be the opposite! I hope you didn't wish to become filthy rich!" Ben Brown chuckled as the young teen blushed at her small error.

It was all in jest though, as Jessica set the cake down, handing the knife over to Daisy. "Birthday girl cuts the cake! Hope you like it, I made it myself."

Daisy sliced into it greedily as she licked her lips. She had a serious weakness for sweet treats, and cake especially fit the bill. "Oh my god, this is cheesecake... with strawberry filling in the center... my favorite!"

Jessica smiled as she kept her professional distance. Despite being Daisy's friend, she was primarily an employee of Stonewall's, so she was always careful to not get too deeply personal with either of the two of them. "Your uncle told me this was your favorite, so I made sure to bake it with care. I hope you like it."

Plus, this was the most difficult cake I've ever baked. You'd think I'd be better at this. Jessica kept that thought to herself as she watched the birthday girl slice into the rich, delicious

looking cake. Sadly, the cake was too small for all of the guests to have a slice, but she had baked many other goodies in preparation for the occasion. This crowd would be satisfied, no matter what.

Daisy cut up her cake, setting aside one slice that happened to have a whole seedless cherry still embedded in it. "This one is for me, I hope nobody minds!" Naturally, nobody objected to this one little request from the birthday girl.

Daisy glanced over at her uncle, as she held up a slice of cake. "Uncle Vasily! Do you want a slice? It's really g-..." She paused, as she watched her uncle swallow some pain pills, his hands shaking slightly as he lifted a glass of water to his mouth. A few seconds later, he swallowed them all in one gulp, as he shook his head silently.

Right. He can't have sweets. Doctor's orders. Sugar increases the replication rate of the nanobots... Daisy suddenly felt a chill wash over her body. *That was selfish of me. Of course he feels left out, and I just taunted him with sweets without thinking. I'm the worst.*

Ben stood nearby, watching the young girl carefully as her face darkened and her smile evaporated. "Daisy, is something the matter?"

The people around her milled about, serving themselves sweets and other such things as they pleased, but Ben stayed to the side, ignoring the plethora of food. He noted with disdain that none of them had even noticed the sudden change in mood from the birthday girl.

"No, Exalt. It's nothing." Daisy forced a smile as she quickly went back to serving slices of cake to the people around her.

Ben stared silently at the young girl. *I hope Stonewall was wrong when he spoke to me earlier. He'll have to have the talk with her later. Let us pray it is mere speculation.*

Daisy sighed contentedly as she held her stomach. Sitting down in her cute little recliner, she plopped down next to her uncle as Jessica banged and bobbed around in the kitchen, cleaning up the leftovers and dishes the party-goers had left behind.

"Are you feeling okay, Uncle Vasily? Tired at all?" She reached over and put her hand on his as she smiled sweetly. Her uncle was, of course, her most beloved person in the world. Her rescuer, the one who had given her the ability to live her life as she pleased without fear of reprisal. He had broken her shell down and introduced her to the joys of living, even if he never could be a true replacement for her deceased parents.

If there was one thing she knew, it was that she loved her uncle, very dearly.

Stonewall coughed quietly as he raised a trembling hand up to his sunken eyes. His eyes were pure white now, all the color having been eaten away by the nanobots over the last year or

so. Visible dark lines extended all over his body. Aggressive magnetic and electric pulse treatments had done little to slow the crawl of the cancer in his body, but it had wreaked havoc on his physical appearance, giving his skin a sort of ashen look to it, almost a ghostly appearance. The texture of his skin too... it was always sort of *damp*, as if he was constantly sweating. This meant that even a slight breeze could give his entire body a deathly wind chill and send him into an asthmatic attack.

"Da. Am feeling great, my sweet niece. Are your studies going well?" Stonewall smiled slightly, lying through his teeth. Daisy, of course, could read his mind if she so chose, but ever since the last time she had done that and ran off to her room sobbing, she didn't try to do it anymore.

Daisy played along, pretending with the acting ability of an Academy Award nominated actress that she wasn't at all saddened by her uncle's appearance. "My studies are going well, as you know. I'm a straight A student! I've also managed to reduce crime in my district by over twenty-four percent!"

"Is good, very good. I am glad to hear." Stonewall swallowed quickly as he felt a cough coming, the effect simply making the cough erupt through his nose as he squeezed his eyes shut in pain. Wheezing and gasping, he jerked his hands up to his mouth as snot erupted from his nose all over his hands.

His ashen face turned rosy red as embarrassment washed over him. He quickly pulled his hands away from his face and grabbed a towel beside his chair as he wiped his hands and face down.

Daisy stared at him in horror, though she tried mightily to keep her expression neutral. She had never seen him lose control like this before. He was a proud man who had never allowed himself to be seen in any sort of humiliating light. Image was everything to him. For him to be like this... his condition must have been getting worse.

"Uncle... have you been administering the pulses every four hours?" Daisy flicked her eyes over to the small box beside his chair. With two arm straps, the goal was to zap the body with several short bursts of energy to try and short some of the nanobots out.

Stonewall shook his head as he put the towel down again beside his chair. "No. Doesn't do shit, anyway. Whole thing is waste of time, hurts for no reason."

Stonewall stared ahead at the wall, unable to look his niece in the eyes after showing such a moment of weakness. Finally, he blinked and sighed. "Please stop the staring. Is very rude, you know."

Daisy quickly averted her eyes. "S-sorry. I didn't mean to... I didn't... mean to..."

Stonewall chuckled quietly, causing Daisy to cock her head in confusion as she turned back to him. "Is funny, really. I am old man, you know? I don't have much time left, my sweet niece. But this day is important for you, so I tried to be strong. Now I've made mess of everything again."

Daisy felt her eyes beginning to tear up. "Don't talk like that. It's just a birthday, it's not even that important. Besides, we don't even know my real birth date anyway. You're more important than some party, Uncle Vasily. You shouldn't push yourself... just for my sake."

Her uncle laughed dryly, his voice weak as it began to crack. "Is true, I guess. We just made up birthday because of day I adopted you... is no real meaning to it." Stonewall shifted his eyes over to his niece, as she dabbed at her eyes with her shirt's shoulders. "Daisy, I have important thing to talk about with you. It cannot wait, since we are on borrowed time as it is."

Daisy felt her stomach flip flop. "D-don't talk like that! You're going to be okay!"

"Hm? No, no my dearest. Am not referring to my life, am referring to yours. I have had suspicion, for long time now, about your abilities, and am filled with worries about them."

"My abilities? What about them?" Daisy felt her sadness disappear as her uncle's eyes betrayed something... different. *Fear*. Something about his tone of voice... this was a serious conversation. "Is there something I need to know?"

Her uncle swallowed as he turned to stare ahead at the TV. A newscaster was discussing the latest robo-bowl projections for who might take the gold this year. "Many things, to be honest. But first, I have philosophical question you must answer."

Daisy nodded as he continued to speak. "You know of Judicator, correct? Jason Hiro is his real name."

His niece smiled slightly. "Yes. I've spoken with him."

Stonewall jerked his head over to look at her again. "You have? When? I do not recall of this meeting."

Daisy blushed as she realized she had never explicitly talked to her uncle about Jason. "Ah, actually, he sort of... rescued me from the labyrinth. Not the Exalt." Her cheeks burned hot red as she quickly met her uncle's eyes. "I'm sorry! I didn't mean to lie about that day! He just asked me to keep our meeting quiet!"

Stonewall shrugged slightly, the movement making him wince as a spasm of pain shot up his back. "Is not big deal. In fact, it makes this question easier. Tell me, what do you know of him?"

"Not much, I guess. He has powers like I and the Enforcers do... he's a time traveler... he seemed nice enough from what I remember of him..."

"As expected." Stonewall nodded as he continued to speak. "Do you know of what the heroes are? Have you heard of them?"

"Sort of. I err, have heard about them from... various people." Daisy tapped her fingers together as she avoided the mention of Marie's name. Best not to mention that unless she had to.

"Da. Again, is expected. Their secrets are closely guarded." Stonewall glanced over at the viewscreen again. "Computer. Close doors. Level red lockdown, this room only. Activate the interference field."

The doors to the room moved of their own volition, closing shut quickly, without slamming as several layers of locks clicked into place. A soft red light appeared in the room, though no audible alarms sounded off.

"This matter is very secret. You understand, of course? No speak of this to anyone. *Anyone*."

Daisy nodded as she swallowed carefully. Her uncle had only ever done this twice in her life that she could remember, and both times it was to discuss privately various things with a certain silver-haired man. Given he wore an energy nullifier at all times, Daisy had never been able to read his mind or deduce his identity, but she knew he was someone extremely important to her uncle's behind the scenes shadow government.

Stonewall turned back to his viewscreen. "Computer, authorization code Stonewall-Silver-four-eight-one-five. Display all files on Type Three Energy candidates."

A massive number of files appeared simultaneously on the viewscreen before them, the sheer number of things onscreen making it impossible for Daisy to focus on anything.

Stonewall stared carefully at the screen for a moment, his eyes flicking from here to there. "Display files on Jason Leonardo Hiro. Filter to only documents pertaining to his known abilities."

Daisy stared in wonder as several new reports began to play silently in the background, their captions indicating the many incredible things he had done. "Wow, he seems incredible."

"Da. Incredibly dangerous. Is why I dismissed him from Earth's defense. One who can destroy planet without authorization is one I am not able to trust. End of story." Stonewall flicked over to some images of various scenes. "He terraformed Mars. He can teleport and create portals to other parts of the universe, as well as other dimensions. He can fire massive energy beam that shreds capital class spaceships. He created indestructible hypersuits and dartfighters. He has destroyed entire planet. And... he can time travel. Most importantly though, he appears to be immortal, but without use of nanobots."

Stonewall turned and eyed his daughter knowingly. "He is unstoppable. We have no defense against him. He has entire army of clones, each one able to destroy a planet by themselves. Even if we were able to take him down, capture him, or kill him, one of his clones would just take his place. We have no countermeasure against a demon of such power, even if he calls himself 'hero'."

Daisy nodded slowly. "Why are you telling me this, uncle? You're not usually so chatty."

"Is important to put in context. Daisy, tell me this. What would happen if Jason was not immortal? What if he had died of old age?"

Daisy stared at her uncle blankly. "I... don't know?" She glanced at the screen uneasily. "Uncle Vasily... I... about heroes..."

Her uncle cocked an eyebrow. "Hmm?"

"I was in the labyrinth when Jason saved me and... well, while I was captured, there was a woman. Her name was Marie... I think you might know her."

Stonewall's jaw tilted downwards slightly as he struggled to maintain his frame. "Marie Becker. You spoke with her... in the labyrinth?"

"Yes."

"I see." Stonewall kept his expression neutral. Daisy could simply read his mind if she wanted to know what rage was floating around in his mind, but of course she wouldn't do that. She was a good girl. "Continue."

"...Marie told me about heroes, and how their power transfers and gets stronger over time. She also told me about the... human experiments..." As Daisy mentioned this, her uncle lowered his pure white eyes slightly as a feeling of guilt and shame overtook him.

"Da. Human trials... very messy. You were one of those tested, of course."

"Right. I've heard the regret in your mind, Uncle Vasily. I'll never hold my trials against you. It gave me the power I needed to become strong and independent."

Stonewall suddenly sat up straight in his chair. "Daisy. Daisy... about... about the trials..."

Usually so calm and collected, her uncle found it difficult to speak for some reason. Daisy was quick to pick up on this. "What is it? What's wrong?"

He tapped his fingers on the chair nervously. "Is why I wanted to speak with you tonight. It is about your abilities... and Jason Hiro... remember how I asked you what would have happened if he had died of old age?"

Daisy nodded. "Yes. What about it?"

"Well, when you were injected, you acted like no other human had before to the type 3 energy. No woman had ever survived an injection... but you not only survived, you gained many incredible powers, and continue to gain more all of the time."

Daisy blinked slowly. "Are... are you saying that... there's something more to me? To my abilities?"

Stonewall quickly raised a hand up. "I am not sure. Anything could be the case. Perhaps you were just lucky. Perhaps you were injected with more potent energy. Perhaps you have special gene in blood that made the injection extra effective. I do not know."

Her uncle smiled sadly, as he stared his niece in the eyes. "I believe, however, that you were to be next hero. Jason would have died in this timeline, and you would have gained incredible powers. Because of his arrival, everything changed. But the thing is... a heroes' powers activate on their 18th birthday. We do not know when your birthday is, your real one. You might become most powerful hero in existence, if this were to keep up. You must be careful, my sweet niece. For your sake, and the world's sake."

Daisy felt her hands trembling. "If Jason isn't supposed to be here, in this timeline, but because of his appearance we ramped up the human trials, and we injected myself with type 3 energy, but I was already going to be the next candidate... then..."

"The stress could kill you." Stonewall felt a lump in his throat as he said this. He didn't want to say it, but it might be the truth. Best to simply get it out there.

Daisy's shoulders slumped as she sagged into her chair. "Unbelievable. Still, you might be wrong, right?"

"Da. I pray all the days that I am wrong. But then, if you were even more powerful hero, you might be able to stop him. If he became too powerful, you might be able to put an end to his reign. You are secret weapon, possibly, against his monstrous unchecked power."

Daisy turned and stared at the viewscreen, her eyes settling on an image of Jason's face from when he was younger. *If he becomes evil, it will be my responsibility to put an end to him. I see now. My uncle is scared for me, but if this is why I was born... this is just.*

"Thank you, Uncle Vasily, for trusting me with this information. I won't let you down." Daisy grinned at her uncle, feeling a sense of relief wash over herself. *Everything is going to be all right, then.*

Stonewall returned the smile weakly, his trembling hands reaching over to grab his water glass, as he accidentally knocked it off the stand. Water spilled all over the floor as he cursed at

himself. "Damn! Stupid idiot. Computer, put end to lockdown. Authorization code Stonewall-Silver-one-five-one-six."

He turned back to his niece. "Go and get Jessica. She will clean this up."

"Sure thing, Uncle."

Daisy smiled as she felt a hop in her step. This was good news, not bad news! Everything was going to work out! What could possibly go wrong?

Part 319a:

Silver felt his hands shaking slightly as he waited in the lobby of the New Bohemian Grove resort. Things were going well, of course, but one could never be too sure of their security these days. Especially when it came to maintaining his grip on power and a secure lifestyle, whilst placating those above him.

For some people, they merely existed to consume, or just to further their own existence. Long term plans went to the wayside as their own greed took precedence over the chance at furthering humanity's ambitions. For himself, though, his goal was to make a difference. Humanity had many enemies, but most of those enemies mattered little to those who pulled the strings.

No... these men cared little for the peons of the world. They had their own agenda, and their greed far outstripped even the most vile scum in any ghetto spawned from the worst cities of the world. Moreover, their methods were awful, even by his own standards.

"Agent Silver, the Lady Victoria will see you now." A big burly looking Englishman walked over and growled at him, turning away and continuing back to the elevator without waiting for a response. Silver sighed as he stood up quickly and followed along.

As the door closed behind the both of them, Silver eyeballed the man silently. He was exactly the sort of person that was always hired to work for these people. A big, stupid oaf, who never asked questions and only did exactly as he was told for a big fat paycheck. The psychological training he had likely endured to make sure no torture technique would work on him to reveal information had likely been even more intense than most would face, given he worked directly under Mrs. Rothschild.

Silver coughed quietly, feeling his throat dry up as the door opened onto the fortieth floor. Her room was directly across from the elevator and it hooked directly up to the roof's hoverpad in case she ever needed to make a quick escape. Of course, her parked hovertank was equipped with the latest in defense technology so she would be assured of making it out with her own life intact.

The burly guardsman silently pulled the door open to her room without knocking. The handle was equipped with technology to unlock when certain people's hands touched it, using the latest in biometric technology to determine their identity.

Silver stepped in the room, using all of his power to stifle his shaking hands. Inside the main hall of this room, several doorless entryways led to other adjoining rooms, though the bedroom

was of course sealed so only she might enter. Silver walked past all of the entryways without looking in, given a casual glance at something he shouldn't have seen would mean the end of his life.

At the end of the hall, he arrived in an ornate dining room, with an adjoining kitchen visible from its massive doorway. A long table stood, with several dozen chairs lined up on both sides, and two ornate chairs placed at both ends.

"Jacob. Timely, as always." A beautiful young woman who appeared to be no older than twenty-four years old sat at the far end of the long table, staring at him unsmiling as he entered. Despite her incredible good looks, ravishing red hair, and the elegant white dress she wore, her expression was hardened enough to melt steel.

Silver flicked a glance down to his wristwatch. It showed he was precisely one minute ahead of schedule, as expected. "Mrs. Rothschild, a pleasure to see you as always."

Despite his polite words and friendly smile, she didn't return the expression. She never smiled. She seemed to be a beautiful young woman who hated everything in the world and wished death upon all of it. Still, her assets meant one had to gain favor with her if they wished to reshape society, so she was quite popular in many circles.

"Sit. Roast duck is on the meal tonight, along with various other sorts of... commoner food." Her dislike of the cuisine for the last few decades was evident. Ever since the Americas had been wiped out or taken over by the demons, a vast amount of rare ingredients had been lost, meaning her favorite delicacies were in very short supply, as the world fought to rebuild its food supply on such limited land. Of course, given when she had access to, she still ate better food than commoners, and replicators were still a thing, but it just didn't taste the same as a professionally cooked meal made with actual ingredients.

Silver quickly took a seat at the opposite end of the table, feeling the massive table between them was a dividing chasm, meant to relegate the inferiors as far away from herself as possible. "Thank you, Mrs. Rothschild. What is the reason you called for me?"

He forced a smile across his face, even knowing she had no intention of returning it. "Jacob, darling. I've been looking into your movements as of late. They seem quite bizarre. I called you here today so you might explain yourself in exhaustive detail."

He waited a few moments, but she didn't elaborate. "Ah, I beg your pardon, but I'm not sure what you're referring to."

"Jason Hiro. Vasily Sokolov. The demons. The angels. So many things are moving much more slowly than we planned. Why is this?"

Silver scratched his chin as he quickly took a sip of Chateau d'Yquem, an extremely expensive and rare white wine that Victoria owned 99% of the world's remaining stockpiles of. The fact she would leave it here for just any guest to consume told him just how little she cared about the cost of things.

"I'm doing the best I can. As you know, ever since Marie's conspiracy with the demons, we lost many of our best American agents. Stonewall is a ruthless man, but our cancer was too aggressive. It neutralized him completely, leaving a more careful and calculating man in charge. Benjamin Brown hates the demons too, but unlike Stonewall, he's not going all-out to eradicate our enemies. He keeps holding back, trying to make sure our troops survive each encounter."

Victoria rolled her eyes. "An idealist. I've read his file, seems he's always been one to hesitate when given an objective. We need someone else in command. Someone much dumber and more brutal. The lives of ants matter little when it comes to eradicating our shared enemy."

A small bell was suddenly heard, as the chef delivered the first course out to them. Roast duck, of course, was first on the list, followed by several other niceties, but Silver mostly ignored them. He wasn't really here for food, he was here to talk business.

The wine, of course, was a rare exception.

"Dumber? Don't you mean 'more obedient'? We need a cunning commander, given the enemy is Marie. She continually evades us no matter how we try. We don't even know about her origins. We don't know a thing about our biggest threat... how can we fight an enemy we don't understand?"

Victoria's normally stern expression contorted itself into a glare as she took a small bite of the duck. "Excuses, is it? Lately, that seems to be all I can wring out of the men around me. Marie is a smart woman, yes, but I'd expect you to have the upper hand, given the vast resources at your disposal. She merely has the aid of technologically illiterate demons. They should have been crushed hundreds of years ago, let alone recently with the weaponry we have now."

Silver stifled a grimace. Naturally, this sheltered woman had little idea of the fight he had been undergoing his whole life. "Are you questioning my abilities? Demons are hardy creatures that have used their vast magical power to create an entirely new dimension, as have the angels. They possess the ability to bend the laws of physics, and even they pale in comparison to the power of the last five heroes. The heroes can ignore the laws of physics outright, while we are still constrained by them. We may seem like a finely tuned war machine marching on a village of primitives, but I assure you, these primitives have their own deadly weapons. Not to mention they have the aid of one of the most intelligent of our kind... we're quite evenly matched."

Silver licked his lips, suddenly realizing he was perspiring heavily. Victoria glared him down from across the table, the same piece of duck speared onto her fork that she had been holding perfectly still for the last 15 seconds. She did not appear to be pleased by his outburst.

"Evenly matched? Every video I've seen from the raiding groups inside that accursed labyrinth indicated we are slaughtering them wholesale. Just send in the Dreadnaughts and eradicate the threat. It's not that difficult."

Silver finally released a long, sad groan of annoyance. "All right, come on now. This is very complicated business. If we send in the Dreadnaughts without any Enforcers to back them up, one EMP will net Marie a hefty force of automatons and will increase her firepower directly. Conversely, just sending in Enforcers is a death wish against the higher demons... their power is magnitudes greater than the lower demons. Finally, even a mixture of both can lead to issues. Last year there was an incident where a Dreadnaught activated an anti-energy pulse, nearly taking out its own company. This issue is not so black and white."

Victoria nodded for a few moments as she digested his words. On one hand, she didn't like having her authority challenged, on the other hand, few men had the balls to do so, and it was therefore a rare occurrence. Silver was one of only a handful who would ever have the nerve to talk back to her like that. "So if we're damned if we do, damned if we don't, then what is the solution?"

Silver smiled uneasily. "I'm working on something, as always. It's directly related to Stonewall's adopted niece, Daisy. If Jason Hiro is out of the picture, I think we might be able to use her powers to our advantage. Heroes have always been the main weapon against the demons, and she would make a very suitable replacement for his loss."

"Hmm. Daisy, yes. I've heard the name in passing. Wasn't she a reject from Facility 02? What use is she?"

Silver cocked an eyebrow as he speared a forkful of duck into his mouth. Chewing it silently, he swallowed a moment later. "I'm surprised you don't know. Daisy was the most powerful Enforcer candidate in the program. Her abilities bloomed unnaturally, and she would constantly lose control. She no longer has those issues anymore and is in full control. Her abilities are extensive too, and seem to have grown substantially since she was there. There's also the matter of her bloodline, which we're still tracing. The results aren't substantiated yet, but there appears to be a... tentative link to a friend of ours from the past."

Victoria chewed another bite of food slowly. "A friend? Explain."

Silver nodded as he reached into his pocket, pulling out his datapad. "I'm sending you the details. Again, none of this is fully confirmed yet, but there are some indications the theory

might be correct."

Victoria tapped a small button on her side of the table, activating a small display. Glancing through the contents of the file she had just received, she spooned some yams into her mouth as she carefully read about the big discovery. "How were you able to find these links? I was under the impression that family trees had little to do with who receives the power."

"New advancements in archaeology. I told you last year, didn't I? We were working on something big. A predictive algorithm. It's just luck this little girl fell into our hands before we even knew what we were doing."

"Luck, indeed. You always seem to have that special knack for getting lucky. Are you perhaps a Hero yourself? Is that your special power?" Victoria spoke blandly, the joking nature of the question belied by the utter drollness she exuded with every breath. In fact, it was less of a joke and more of mockery.

"Heh heh... I guess?" Silver forced another insincere smile as he finished off the small portion on his plate. He wasn't very hungry, having eaten a while ago, but this food was made by a world class cook so it was always worth nabbing a bite here and there.

Victoria turned her gaze back to the datapad. "Well, whatever the case, Stonewall is in the way. He's too decrepit to be of use to me. If he's gone, we'll have exclusive access to the girl without him interfering. So, in conclusion, eliminate Stonewall, deliver me some good news about the demons, and make sure we're progressing steadily towards our goals."

Silver stared ahead at the young looking woman uneasily. "I don't mean to question an order... but Stonewall is unwell because of our nanobots. He might be in the way, but he would have been a more effective leader if you hadn't sought to weaken him."

Victoria nodded as she took a sip of her favorite wine. "Indeed. However, he was getting too close. Despite my insults to the contrary, he was cunning when it came to matters of the military. If he had found out what was going on with the newest Mars colony, it would have been disastrous. It's good he's out of the way now. Benjamin Brown can lead for a while longer until we find a new puppet."

Silver rose from the table slowly, standing up to his full height. "Very well, I understand. We need to eliminate Stonewall for good, instate a new puppet, and get control of Daisy. Anything else?"

"No. That will do. You're a professional as always, Jacob."

"Thank you, Mrs. Rothschild." Silver bowed gracefully as he walked out of the room a moment later.

The objectives sounded so simple... but he had a feeling they would not work out as smoothly as she wanted.

Part 320a: Turning Tides

Satan smirked as he held the metal band in his grasp, noting with disinterest the small metallic circle in the center of it. It resembled a wristwatch, but without a face to tell time.

"You're very good at jokes." He chuckled as he dangled it in midair daintily with two fingers. "What is this? I don't have time for stupidity."

Marie smirked as she licked her lips. "My ticket to immortality. It took me half a year to get the designs up, but with a small amount of field testing and some tweaks, I assure you it works perfectly now."

"It? What is 'it'?" Satan cocked an eyebrow as he pulled it apart with both hands, examining the bland metal trinket with just a hint of interest now. "What is the function of this little plaything?"

"This is the key to my permanent existence. It's a defensive device that will give you the ability to fight on the level of the humans. It creates a local area force field around the user intended to specifically nullify anti-energy attacks. Meaning... if a demon wears this and gets shot by a Dreadnaught's 80mm cannon, they'll survive the hit."

Satan's eyes widened slightly as he examined it more carefully. "Really, now? This small thing? I find that difficult to believe. I'm not very well versed when it comes to the intricacies of human engineering, but this seems too small to perform such a monumental task."

Marie nodded. "It is, actually. This is only capable of nullifying one massive anti-energy attack before its internal battery dies, or a few smaller ones. The only way to improve it would be to create a much bigger, bulkier model. However, those would hinder the combat effectiveness of our forces, but they would have an even more significant downside in that they would be much slower and difficult to mass produce. This is the most effective prototype I've created."

Satan's face contorted into a wicked grin as he suddenly felt a large weight lift off his shoulders. "Ahh, Marie. This is exactly what I wanted. Impressive, I must say. It's unfortunate that I won't be able to turn you into a mindless slave in the end, but I am suitably impressed. You completed this prototype well ahead of schedule and under budget, which is very important."

Satan's smile faded as his expression darkened. "The humans have stopped needing to reverse engineer our portals. They are now capable of harnessing type 2 energy to create their own portals, and they've been able to start targeting sensitive areas for invasion. They're also

pushing us back on the surface of their world, and all of this is happening without the aid of the angels. We're lucky that Zeus and Gabriel are content to merely grow their anti-war cult, since that weakens humanity somewhat... but things are looking dark for our future."

His smile came racing back in an instant as he held the trinket up in the air for all to marvel at. "At least now we have the ability to survive for more than ten seconds! With this, we can begin sending our most powerful and valuable assets to the frontline!"

Marie grinned. "Not so fast. I'd be happy to make more for you, as many as you want, but we had a *deal*."

Satan's smile fell away again as he lowered his arms. "Haaah, yes yes. I understand. Immortality. Before I give you this, however, I would advise that you think about it carefully. Immortality, even only the type that grants long life, has many downsides, not least of which is outliving those who are mortal. Are you sure you wish to proceed? Since the contract has been resolved in your favor, you have the right to cancel it now."

Marie didn't even blink. "Do it. I don't care if I outlive the inferiors of my species. Nanobots are too dangerous and too easy to tamper with."

Satan chuckled. "Right you are. Very well, you shall have your wish. Contract!" Speaking the last word, the magical contract appeared in the air before him as he placed his hand on it. The contract glowed for a moment as it then dissolved into the ether, never to be seen again. "It is done."

Marie blinked. "Is that it? I don't feel any different."

"Heh, of course you don't. You never will. You can't age a day from today. However, those nanobots you injected decades ago are still there. I advise you find a way to get rid of them, since they are less useful to you than my immortality, and they will continue to hurt you forever if you can't rid yourself of them."

Marie started to ask how he knew she had injected nanobots, but then she realized how obvious it was. She was well over a hundred years old, but unlike the other fools of the world, she had carefully created her own strain of them, meaning that short of a better scientist hacking the frequencies hers operated at, hers would not fall prey to the false nano-cancer running rampant now. Funny, nobody had yet bothered to ask why it only seemed to regularly affect high ranking political opponents of the Illuminati, or people in the ghetto that dragged down the IQ of the human race. The 'purity' of the Illuminati's creed was one she felt disgusted by.

"Well, if you truly did give me full immortality, I thank you. I will begin mass producing these devices at once. If you'd like, I could make some more effective ones for yourself and your

generals, since they're strong enough to wear the heavier models without greatly diminishing their combat effectiveness."

Satan shrugged. "I don't need them. Anti-energy is only effective if it can hit the one it is targeted at. I move far too quickly for it to hit me, so these bands would be a hindrance more than anything." He paused a moment as he glanced down at the device in his hands. "Come to think of it, why not just wear several of these bands? Wouldn't that protect the user several times over?"

"No." Marie spoke bluntly. "It would protect them far less effectively. The bands would interfere with one another, to the point they might even just cancel each other out. In fact, my field tests indicated that it could cause severe neurological feedback to the user if they wore several at once and were hit by an anti-energy attack... assuming the attack didn't kill them first. They would become a vegetable."

Satan nodded. "I see. Very valuable information. Begin making them at once. We're in need of as many as you can create. If you need helpers or assistants, let me know."

Marie chuckled as she eyed the sly devil. *He thinks he's going to continue receiving my help for free. Isn't that just cute.*

I've made significant progress.

Swinging Excalibur at a highly condensed rock, I slice through it as if it wasn't even there. It's not the blade that's powerful, it's my control of its energy. Excalibur isn't just any weapon, it's a high-powered magical cannon with a blade that can cut through anything, provided you finely channel energy along its edge. In effect, I transform it from a sword into a chainsaw that can slice through any substance, but the amount of energy and the frequency must be finely tuned. Pouring energy into the blade is a poor substitute for carefully manipulating it with my mind.

The process is exhausting but yields incredible results. What is even more amazing though is that Arthur was able to do this from the very start without it causing him any trouble. Truly incredible.

I feel someone approaching my training room aboard the Mothership, instantly noting that it's Amelia. I quickly store the blade away as she opens the door. She would possibly recognize it, having fought with Arthur in the past, though I can't be sure with how poor her memory is.

"What'cha doin'?" Amelia saunters up to me, her usual bored expression covering up any underlying thoughts. I've debated reading her mind, but given the feedback I received from that *thing* in the past, it seems a bad idea.

"I'm just messing around, trying to test my abilities. I'm kind of bored myself, for once." I feel my eyes lower. "Actually, there's something else. Stonewall, the leader of humanity, is apparently in critical condition and hanging on to life by a thread. Agent X informed me of this."

Amelia shrugs. "I don't know who he is. A friend of yours?"

I almost feel my lip curl up into a sneer, though I catch myself. She doesn't know. It wasn't her fault. "No. He's an enemy. He's a very evil man. Once, I thought he might do good for humanity, perhaps his methods would push the demons out. Now I know he is evil. He killed a dear friend of mine. He has oppressed the people of Earth. His death would only make me happier if I were the one sticking the knife in his heart."

Amelia frowned. "That doesn't sound like something you would usually say." She walks up to me as she loops her arm through mine. "You're a good guy! Don't be bad! Nobody likes a bad person."

I start to respond but I feel awkward suddenly, with her youthful figure pressed up against me like this. "Ah, what are you doing?"

She pulls away almost immediately as her hand rolls down my arm and back to her side. For a moment, I almost think I catch a flash of sadness cross her face. "Err, nothing. Sorry... I forgot you don't like that."

"Well, it's not that I like or don't like it, I just..." I feel myself blushing as I wipe my forehead. Fuck's sake, I'm well over a hundred years old and have had several sexual conquests at this point, why am I blushing like a schoolboy?

I mean, Amelia is very attractive now. She doesn't look like a child anymore, she's been a better person than I have for decades... what the hell is wrong with me? Why do I refuse to allow any intimacy between us? It even seems to be hurting her. Hell, what if somehow my refusal of her causes her to go down the wrong path out of anger that I'm not reciprocating her feelings?

Then again, what if reciprocating her feelings changes something in her and makes her evil? I don't know anything about the past. I don't-

"What are you thinking about?" Amelia stares at me with concern and I realize I had drifted off into my own world for several moments, leaving her hanging.

"Just... stuff. About us. Our, err, relationship."

"Oh?" Her disinterested look belies the curiosity in her question. There's something going on under the surface.

"Look, it's like, we're friends, you know? Just friends. Isn't it fine if we keep it that way?"

"Why?" Her one word response leaves me grasping for straws. I'm not sure how to respond to it.

"That's just the way it is, I suppose?"

She frowns at me. "What a terrible answer. You're really wishy-washy sometimes, you know?"

Man, this conversation came out of thin air. I was not prepared for this at all. "Yeah... I know."

Her frown turns into almost an expression of anger as she glares at me. "You know, there's something about you that's been really pissing me off. Ever since we met, we've hung out, fought together, played together, and done all sorts of great things... but you always keep me at arm's length! Why? Am I not pretty? Do you secretly hate me?!"

Her anger is genuine and it catches me off guard. She hasn't released a single negative emotion in decades. In fact she's been the epitome of tranquility, like a revered Buddhist monk. "I... I don't understand where this anger is coming from, Amelia. I thought it would be okay if we stayed like we were."

"Well it's not! You never once asked me about my feelings. I've been a good girl for years and years! I keep trying to make you happy, but you never consider me at all!"

I take a step backwards as her barrage hits me. Is this true? She was being good just because she liked me? That sounds preposterous, given her past. Am I thinking incorrectly? I tend to overthink things and I'm not good at taking the initiative. Amelia isn't the same girl as the one I knew in the future. This one has surely done bad things, but she hasn't devoured a planet. She's been... a good girl...

"W-what exactly do you want then? I'm... listening now."

Her face turns red as she flips her head away. "I don't know. You're a guy, you're supposed to know what to do. Why not just do what they do in those moving box pictures?"

I cock an eyebrow in confusion, then I remember she's been watching a lot of old movies from the previous century, before art become pastel and holographic in nature. Good god, has she been watching romance movies? What exactly does she think should be, err, happening now?

"Ah. Well, I mean... if that's what you want... we could maybe go on a date... or whatever..."

She jerks her head back to look me in the eye again, a look of embarrassment visible. "A date? Is that like chess or something?"

"It could involve chess, I suppose. Then again, dates are for kids and teenagers. Maybe that's not the best way to proceed..." My eyes drifted up to the ceiling as thoughts swirled around. Damn, now that I think about it, I don't know what to do here. My previous interactions with women were a hundred years ago in my time scale, and there was less of that involved. It just sort of... happened.

I glanced down and realized Amelia was standing right in front of me now, as she reached over and took both of my hands in her own small hands. "We're already good friends though. We don't need to bother with that silly stuff. Let's just forget the mistakes and start from scratch. How about that?"

I swallow hard as I feel the closeness between us. "Yeah, that sounds good."

I wasn't ready for this. But, somehow, I will be okay. *We* will be okay. This might be exactly what the both of us needed.

Part 321a: Confrontation 2

The lighting in the room was very dim. The lights were so low that if Daisy didn't have the special vision types granted by her superhuman abilities, she might not even be able to see her uncle's face from the two or three feet that she sat from him.

His breath came in shallow bursts, his chest rising and falling at an unsteady rhythm that matched the spasms of pain he felt in his body. Daisy kept her hand hovering over his head as she sent pain neutralization waves into his mind, but it was too little, too late. Her uncle Vasily was dying. This might be his last day alive.

Daisy pulled one hand away to wipe a stray tear from her eye before she returned to focusing on sending soothing mental pulses into his mind. Really, she knew it was hopeless. Even with all the powers she held, the nanobots were too virulent. Nothing she did was able to save him now.

As she sat at his bedside, her uncle's personal assistant, Jessica, walked in the room. She kept her voice low, almost at a whisper. "Is he able to sleep, young miss?"

Daisy nodded slowly, barely able to parse the question.

"You should take a break. This is draining you mentally, and if you keep your use of your abilities constant like that, it might have severe consequences."

Jessica put her hand on Daisy's shoulder, but Daisy shrugged it off. "I can't. My uncle needs me now. He'll die if the pain continues like this."

He's going to die anyway, as it is. Jessica almost wanted to say that, but she stopped herself. Of course Daisy knew this fact. Jessica found herself grateful that Daisy was so busy focusing on her uncle or a stray mind-reading might have caught that thought. Best to leave before she let something awful slip out.

"All right. If you need me, let me know. I'll be in the kitchen cooking lunch up."

Jessica left the room, closing the door behind herself silently.

Daisy bit her lip as she continued to send pulses into her uncle. This just wasn't right. There had to be a cure. She lacked the power, but angels and demons existed, beings that broke the supposed laws of physics. Magical energy was real, and just waiting to be harnessed, yet despite her position as the most powerful human on Earth... she wasn't strong enough to save her uncle.

No... that wasn't right. Daisy furrowed her brow in concentration. She wasn't the most powerful human on Earth. There was another. Jason Hiro... Judicator. He was a time traveler born of the heroic lineage. He had unbelievable powers dwarfing even her own. He had destroyed an entire planet, created unstoppable battle suits and ships, and could travel across the entire galaxy in the blink of an eye. If he couldn't save her uncle... who could?

Yes... that was it! Jason Hiro had the power!

Daisy stood up from the bed, as she sent a quick telepathic signal to Jessica. The young woman entered the room quickly, her breathing sharp as she looked around in alarm. "What is it? What's going on?"

"I need you to watch uncle Vasily. I'm going to find the one person who can save his life."

Jessica stared at her blankly. "I don't think you should make a deal with the devil."

"What? No! I'm going to find Jas- err, Judicator. He has the power to save my uncle! Or rather, if he doesn't, nobody does!"

Jessica shot a glance over at Stonewall's body, now breathing more quickly and in faster breaths as the pain was no longer being suppressed. "I thought your uncle had a major falling out with him. Why would he help you now?"

"I don't know, but I have to try! If I don't, I'll never be able to forgive myself!"

The two blonde girls nodded at each other in agreement. "Fine. You'd best make it quick then. Lord knows we're both aware he hasn't much time left."

Daisy quickly pushed past the other girl, touching her shoulder as she walked past. "You know my holo-watch ID. If anything changes, you-"

Jessica cut her off. "Just go! No time to sit around gabbing!"

Daisy shoved through the door as she raced up to their hoverpad on the roof. They had exactly one space-worthy vessel, and luckily it was a fast one.

Now to just figure out where in the entire space above Earth it was that Judicator had parked his spaceship.

It all happened so fast. One minute we were talking, then she hugged me, then I leaned down and kissed her... and now...

Now I'm in bed with a woman who may just be the worst serial killer in humanity's history, besides myself of course. I suppose we both now exist in the moral grey area of 'evil but our intentions were good'.

With the covers pulled over top of us, Amelia is now dozing off beside me, both of us having had a good time last night. Physically, we did. Mentally... I'm not sure. Why do I have so many doubts? I was 18 when I met her in the future. I lived with her for a long time, fought alongside her... she saved my life twice... and then ultimately she died at my hands. I killed her. I suppose technically I might say that Hoarhiim did, but I bear much of that burden as well.

And yet here we are, laying together in the same bed. She doesn't even know what I did to her in the future. Is that why I hesitate? Maybe it's not because I think she's evil, but because of my own guilt.

In fact, after last night, I'm sure of it. I have to come clean. I have to tell her the truth. We can't have dishonesty between us. What if this causes her to snap? At least I have the advantage that if she does turn evil again, I can use my abilities to end her with a single word. She doesn't know about how my abilities work yet, so this is still an option. Even if it weren't though, I'm reasonably sure that with the power of hypersuits, I could defeat her in combat.

God... listen to me. I just had a great time with this wonderful girl last night who seems to implicitly trust and love me, yet all I do is think about how I'll kill her if she turns on me. I'm the worst.

I'm the worst.

It's dark in the room when I open my eyes. In Britannian time, it's probably 3:30 AM or so, the dead of night. Hours are meaningless in space and my body has long since adapted to a longer 36 hours cycle... but still.

I glance down to Amelia and feel my heart skip.

Her eyes are open.

Her eyes are pitch black.

I jerk away from her in fright. What the hell? This isn't a hallucination. She's just staring at me with these d-demonic saucer-sized eyeballs. It's hideous.

" Had a good time, did you? "

An unbelievably deep, evil sounding voice comes from her mouth... a voice that sounds horrific and alien... yet familiar.

"Who the hell are you?" I get out of bed quickly, tossing the covers to the side as I stand up, naked, and stare down at the form of the young woman laying motionless in the bed.

" I'm asking the questions here, filth. You insipid insect. I grow tired of the lies, the deceptions. I won't allow you to simply have your way anymore, not so long as you foolishly continue to weaken the seal on my vessel. "

"Your vessel? Amelia?" Curiously, I note that her body is still completely still, laying front-first with her arms pressing the pillow up against her face. She hasn't budged an inch.

" Indeed. I've protected this one for millennia. Many heroes have fought and died trying to kill her. Yet you continue to play house. You continue to think of yourselves as friends. I am not fooled. I may not know what your final goal is, but I can see clearly that it is not in her best interests. You are her enemy, the worst kind. "

I grit my teeth as I stare into the eyes of a demon far more powerful than even Satan. This monster is no joke. I can feel dark energy seeping from every pore in her body. However, it isn't struggling to break loose. Instead, it seems to be attempting to contain itself.

"You must be her 'friend'. Levvy, I think she calls you. Why have you appeared now?"

Amelia's face remaining totally blank, but the voice filled with venom as it spoke. **" You utter fool. You thought only of using her for your own pleasure, yet failed to think of the consequences. Your seed carries the holy power of heroes, a direct counter to her own energy. She has gone without a meal for well over a decade, and now you introduce a toxin directly into her. You are going to kill her if you keep this up, in a slow, horrific death. I will survive of course, but she will die. Is this what you want? Is this your plan? "**

Despite the ominous demon voice, I felt myself blush. My, err, 'seed'. Right, that. "What are you saying? You have to explain it to me, I don't even get what you are."

The voice paused for several seconds as it seemed to think of a response. **" The princess is under my control right now. She will not hear what I am about to say, as I have sent her mind into a temporary void. Your actions have confused and baffled me for too long, but now I will seek to find out your true intentions. Listen well, descendant of Hercules. I am Leviathan, the most powerful being that has ever existed. By a stroke of fate, I was trapped inside a place I could never hope to escape. This young child took pity on me, and allowed me to seal myself inside of her in order to escape. In my prime, I might have betrayed her in an instant, bursting out of her once back in the real world... but I did not. I changed as a result of her kindness. "**

" Despite this, she suffered because of our union. The power was too great for her body to control. I risked exploding from her on a daily basis. The only way I found to keep myself sealed inside of her was to consume the flesh of humans. Their energy fortified her own, allowing her to resist mine. Understand,

misguided hero that you are, that I cannot leave her body without killing her. If her energy weakens too much, I will be released and she will die. There is no avoiding this truth. "

I felt my breathing sharpen as he spoke. "You're trapped inside of her? You can't leave or she dies? What the hell... this sounds like a horror flick."

" My being trapped inside of her is a blessing and a curse. She will live forever, so long as I am inside of her, and she will never age so long as she is able to resist me, but you have been stifling the hunger inside of her for so long that I am now able to speak directly through her body. Soon, my energy will be strong enough to take direct control. After that, she will surely break and I will be released. The rest, you can parse out for yourself. "

I nodded quickly. "I understand. Clearly, despite being a horrifying demon, you care for her. That must be why you're telling me this. You don't want her to die. What can I do then?"

Leviathan continued to speak, his voice becoming almost conversational in tone. **" Perhaps I have misjudged you. You are quick to think of her well-being. The solution, hero, is for her to consume human flesh. Only energy from a human will counteract my own. "**

I glared at the demonic eyes. "Not a demon, not an angel? Just a human?"

" Only a human. "

"Can I give her some of my energy? I'm human, after all."

" You are a hero. Giving her your energy, as you have already done, is sure to cause my release even faster than it already is bound to happen. Only a regular human will work. Younger is better, too, as humans lose some of their energy as they advance in age. "

I blinked quickly as my expression turned to horror. "Y-you mean a small child?! That's terrible! I can't do that!"

Leviathan chuckled at me. **" I can promise you three things, hero. First, if you don't allow her to consume living human flesh, I will escape from her body. Second, if I escape, she will die. Third, if she dies, I will kill you. You will come to find out just how frail and weak you really are. No power in the universe will be able to kill me, not even your word magic. "**

I quickly took a step back. "Word magic? How do you know about that?"

" I know all and see all, foolish human. I am the last of the eternal dragons, the most powerful of my kind. When my brethren were slain by the Titans of old, their power became mine. Michael was the last slaver to pass, and he is gone as well. My power is unfathomable, comparing only to the Creator himself. I suspect, even, that he might envy me. But enough talk. I have told you what you must do. If my princess dies, I will hold you personally accountable. Never forget that. "

I swallowed carefully as I stared at the lithe form of the girl before me. So innocent and small looking, yet filled with a horrifying monster inside of her. Her very existence was torture. "What of Amelia's wishes? What if she doesn't want to consume and be evil anymore?"

Leviathan's voice suddenly had an edge of sadness to it. **" If she makes that choice, I will respect it. But when she dies, I will still come for you, Jason Hiro. My wrath will border on insanity. She is... she is my... my special... "**

Leviathan paused a moment as he seemed to compose himself, even though Amelia's eyes continued to stare blankly ahead.

" ...that won't matter. None of it will matter. Double cross me, and you will pay the price. Farewell, hero. "

I watched in awe as Amelia's eyes slowly closed and her breathing returned to a steady rhythm. She looked to me now as she did last night when we embraced each other.

Peaceful. Serene. Innocent.

I don't... I don't want her to die. I'm not afraid of that monster inside of her... but I don't wish for her to die. His scare tactics are nothing compared to the thought of her existence vanishing once again at my hands.

I have to save her.

But... how?

My thoughts are disturbed as Harold pops into my mind. Apparently he didn't hear a thing that just happened. "Yo, whippersnapper, yer up! Great! I gots a light cruiser headed o'er here, some girl says she wants tah speak with ya!"

What? This is a bad time. A very bad time.

But... I need to think. I need to clear my head.

"Fine. Let her in the hanger. I'll go down there to meet her. Who is she, anyway?"

Part 322a:

"Heal him? You want me to heal him?"

"Yes! Only you have the ability to do so!"

The young girl stared at me with bated breath as she waited for my response. Daisy, yes, that was her name. She is the most powerful Enforcer on Earth, given the number of abilities Agent X has told me she possesses. Telepathy, telekinesis, enhanced vision, even bursts of super strength.

And she is the niece of a man I most dearly hate. Stonewall. The man who murdered my friend live on a national broadcast. I was too late to save him. Gregory died because of this girl's uncle, and I can never bring him back.

"Your uncle killed a friend of mine. You're so busy asking me if I can, you didn't stop to ask if I should. You're a sweet girl, Daisy, but your uncle is my enemy. And, in my opinion, he's an enemy of mankind."

Daisy's face was fraught with concern. "Come on, I know I'm asking you for a lot, but I'll owe you if you do this for me! I'll- I'll double owe you! Y-you can ask me for anything and I'll do it!"

Anything? Of course my male mind immediately went to the lascivious, but I shook that thought from my brain. "Daisy, I understand he's your uncle and you probably have affection for him..." I paused as I glanced up at the light corvette class ship she had brought along. It was a small vessel, but able to house ten occupants comfortably, and it was clearly designed for speed. "...but I can't just help you with this. It's personal. I think he deserves to die."

Her face was ashen as she heard my words. "No... no you have to help me... if my uncle dies I don't know what I'll do. Please, I'm begging you. You have to help him!"

She wasn't listening to me. I wasn't listening to her. This discussion was fruitless, so far.

"All right fine, calm down a moment. Let's just say I do heal him. Then what? He goes back to ruling humanity with an iron fist? He oppresses more of his fellow humans with dictatorial policies? I can't allow a man like that to live."

The sadness on Daisy's face was replaced with an explosion of anger. "Well, isn't that noble of you? While you abandoned humanity for a decade, my uncle fought to crush the demons and get order under control! You, who killed trillions of sentient beings in the blink of an eye now think of yourself as holier than thou! Get real!"

I flinched from her sudden barrage, but held my ground. "Your anger is understandable, but you're the one asking me for a favor. I can't just go and heal up someone I hate. Besides, I didn't leave Earth due to laziness, I left because your uncle told me to leave. And now that I'm back, I think it's time to fix this colossal error. After your uncle is gone, I need to find someone who will be able to bring Earth back to the way it was before, and improve it if possible."

Daisy sighed as some air whistled between her teeth. "You seem like you have a plan and it doesn't include my uncle, no matter what. Can't you take pity on him? If you heal him, I will make sure he stays out of the way for good. No more politics, I'll force him to retire so that he can't 'hurt' Earth any more than you think he has. Isn't that doable?"

I shrugged again as I eyed the young woman before me. She really was desperate. She wasn't going to take no for an answer.

Then there was the matter of her abilities. If her powers have anything to do with the heroic spirit, in one form or another, then she might make for a terrifying enemy if I pissed her off. Her uncle was just a normal human, and he could be dealt with easily, by Agent X if need be. But this young girl... I should tread more carefully.

"Fine. I'll tell you what... if you really want me to heal your uncle, I want to see him first. Take me to your estate and I'll at least have a look at his condition. I'm not promising anything... but if you feel this strongly and you're willing to follow through on that promise, I'll at least hear you out."

Daisy's eyes lit up like the fourth of July. "Oh wow, really? You'll save him?! Jason, I knew you had it in you!!"

I scratched the back of my head. "Yeah yeah, like I said. No promises. Let's go. Since time is of the essence, we'll skip the hovercar." I grabbed her hand without asking. "Luckily, I know exactly where your uncle's estate is."

She blushed as I held her hand. "You do? How?"

I ignored her question. *Harold. Beam me down to these coordinates.*

It took us a split second to arrive at the outside of the front of her estate. I quickly let go of her hand and started walking towards her front door, as she stumbled along trying to keep up with me. The first time I ever teleported, it felt pretty odd as well. Then again, I had anticipated teleporting, she had not.

I paused as I gave her a second to cope. Finally she blinked her eyes and walked towards me. "That was different from last time. It felt different, like there was electricity pulsing through my body."

I chuckled as we walked up the front steps of her mansion. "My normal teleportation has distance limits, but breaks dimensional limits. My ship's teleporters, however, have much greater distance limits, but far more finite dimensional limits. I use whichever is appropriate for the situation."

She cocked an eyebrow. "Didn't you create a wormhole that allowed us to move a fleet of ships 14,000 light years in the blink of an eye? It defies the laws of reality."

"That's the way magic works. Besides, the wormhole situation was different, very different. Anyway, enough talk. Let's go see your uncle."

She zipped her lips as we entered her mansion. Nobody was there to greet us, oddly enough. "Jessica is with my uncle. She told me she'd message me if anything went wrong."

I nodded carefully. "Jessica, huh? Is she the only servant you have?"

As we walked down a long hallway, Daisy shot me a look of incredulity. "We don't have servants here. We pay for certain people to do various tasks periodically, but Jessica is my uncle's personal assistant. She lives here with us. She has an entire wing all to herself."

I nodded again as I flicked my eyes away. "I see."

Finally, we arrived at the rear end of the mansion at the door to Stonewall's room. Daisy opened it quickly. "How is he?"

What we saw next made my heart catch in my throat.

Stonewall was sitting upright in his bed, calmly looking at a datapad as he flicked through its contents. The viewscreen on the wall displayed several notes about recent happenings in Britannia, while a news report played of a recent terrorist bombing.

"What the hell? He looks perfectly fine." My voice cracked as I barely whispered the words, but Daisy didn't seem to hear me, rushing past me in the blink of an eye.

"Uncle Vasily! You're awake! You're looking good! But how?!"

Another girl in the room, one I hadn't noticed for a moment, stood up from beside his bed. "It was a miracle. Something happened that caused him to get better, all on his own! I've never seen anything like it in my entire life!"

I shot a glance over to the girl. She was a young blonde girl, appearing to be roughly age 22. Very attractive, if I didn't say so myself.

Daisy glanced across the bed at her. "Jessica, you should have told me! I'm so happy I could just cry!"

Stonewall finally stopped staring at his niece long enough to look over at me. "Da. I am feeling quite good now." Despite the fact that his eyes were on me, he spoke to his niece. "Daisy, you brought this man with you? He is not one I would call friend."

I curled up my lip at him, as I started to feel a snarl form. Just as I was about to fire off a retort, Jessica got up from the bed and walked over to me, turning her head back towards Stonewall. "Now now, no need for that. This is a time for happiness. I'll take Jason out so you and Daisy can have some alone time."

"Da. Do that." Stonewall never took his eyes off mine, and I returned the favor. Right up until I was pulled from the room by Jessica and she closed the door, we kept our gazes evenly locked at each other.

I blinked as I realized I was staring at a closed door. Glancing down, I noticed Jessica was standing beside me.

"What the hell are you doing?" I hissed the words at her quietly.

"I am doing what I had to. Come with me a moment." She quickly walked ahead of me as we both walked down the hallway towards the front door. "There are no security cameras or microphones here, but there's also no need for us to speak right in front of the door where those two might hear us."

I grimaced at her words. "Idiot. I didn't order you to heal him. Why did you act without my permission? He's a dangerous man and I hadn't yet made up my mind."

"I did." Jessica and I hitched a left into the mansion's kitchen, where she proceeded to pull a sandwich from the fridge. "Sorry, I'm fucking starving. I've been beside him all day without a moment for myself."

"Yeah." I shrugged nonchalantly as she took a couple bites. "So tell me your reasoning. Why did you decide to make that decision without consulting me?"

She sighed. "Things aren't so black and white. You think of Stonewall as a bad guy, but I've seen the good he's doing. If he's gone, someone worse might come into power."

"That's not good enough. He killed my friend... our friend. He had Gregory murdered and he broadcasted it live to the world. He's a monster."

Jessica glared at me. "I get that you liked Gregory, okay? But I'm a third level clone. You were the one interacting with him, not me. I barely knew him. The person I do know, however, is Stonewall. Besides, if he dies, we don't know what will happen with Daisy. Her powers are incredible, though not at our level yet. Further, she has just celebrated her 18th birthday. Our

powers and the powers of every other hero manifest during our 18th birthdays. If she really is a hero, then..."

"I know, idiot. I've already thought of all that." I groaned at this clone's lack of foresight. "Shit, why didn't you ask me first? How am I going to explain his sudden healthiness? Spontaneous immunity isn't a good enough reason."

Jessica returned the groan. "Gods, sometimes I forget what an idiot you are. Look, just tell her you wanted to surprise her. Tell her you healed him before you even teleported down. She'll buy it. She doesn't know what powers you have anyway, and neither does he."

I reached up and chewed one of my fingernails. This might actually work. Plus, she'd still feel indebted to me, so that was a plus. Always good to have an extra ally, even if by a stroke of luck. And technically if Jessica healed him, then a clone of mine did it, meaning they were partially me, so it was only a white lie...

"Fine. We'll do that. Christ, we'll be lucky if this works out. I hope you know what you're doing, X."

"Don't worry, I'm a professional. Unlike you." She shot me a coy glance. "You ought to try being a girl some time. It's an interesting experience, although I can't tell you how annoying it is being wolf whistled at constantly."

I sighed again. "I'll pass."

After we both ate some food, we waited a few minutes before walking back down the hallway.

Jessica spoke up again. "I'm going to put myself in a trance. This is the only way she won't know who I really am in case she reads my mind. I only break the trance under specific conditions."

"Smart. If you just nullified mind-reading, she might get suspicious."

Perhaps my clone was smarter than I thought. I'd have to learn how she did it.

Part 323a:

"You owe me." I stepped into the room with a cocky smile aimed right at Stonewall.

Stonewall turned and glowered at me. "Owe you? Unlikely."

Daisy also seemed unfazed. "You healed my uncle? I thought you weren't going to?"

"I was testing you. I healed him on the way here, just before we teleported down. I wanted to be sure you were going to keep your word."

Daisy nodded slowly as she remembered our conversation, then she lowered her eyes away from mine. "Oh. Right. My promise."

Stonewall noticed the expression on her face. "Daisy, you agreed to conditions of this man? If he put you into slavery or something, I will kill him."

Daisy shook her head quickly. "N-no, uncle Vasily! It's not like that... I just agreed that if he healed you, I would keep you away from politics."

Stonewall kept his gaze aimed at mine. "Ah, I see. Such a convenient resolution. I am kept out of way, you are indebted to him... perhaps too convenient."

Jessica was standing behind me, as she swallowed. "What do you mean, Mister Sokolov?" She took a step past me and entered the room, standing by his side as she looked from him to me.

"Is so simple, da. Jason infects me with virus, waits until last moment, then heals me to win affection of my beautiful niece. So perfect how it all works out. The only question now is how long it will be before he asks for her hand in marriage!"

Daisy's eyes sparked with recognition even as she blushed somewhat. "That can't be, but... now that you mention it..."

I can see the gears whirring in her head. Goddamnit, now I know why I hate this man so much. He only ever sees what he wants to see. He's also very persuasive, unlike myself.

Fine, it's time for my response. "That's not true, Stonewall. I saved your life. Not only that, I have a lead on who is causing the nano-virus... but it might sound a tad ridiculous."

Stonewall chuckled, even as his glare never wavered. "Try me."

"The Illuminati."

Everyone in the room stared at me for a solid five seconds without saying a word. I continued to stand my ground though, until Stonewall relented. "Is so absurd you would say

such a thing, I must conclude you are telling truth. Suppose this is truth, how would you prove it?"

I shrugged. "I'm not sure. All I know is that as powerful as I am, I'm not smart enough to engineer nanobots, let alone killer ones like the ones in your body. I simply turned them inert inside of you, but the downside of that act is that you will begin to rapidly age. Without the nanobots keeping you young, you're bound to die very soon anyways."

Well, unless I use 'immortality' or 'youth' on him. I would prefer not to do that though.

I kept that thought to myself.

Stonewall chortled at me, though it didn't seem like genuine laughter. "Your alibi is own stupidity? Amusing. A man who pretends to be stupid yet can destroy massive planet by himself. Truly, you are enigma of our time."

Despite his grunts and deflections, Stonewall seemed to relent. He didn't totally buy what I had to say, but he shrugged his shoulders anyway. "Gah! I do owe you, given you have saved my life. Whether you did it for selfish reasons is yet to be seen though. I may be thanking you, but I am not trusting you."

"That's fair." I decided to accept his thanks without complaint. It was a start. Frankly, he's lucky I don't just kill him right here and now. X may think he's a decent leader for humanity, but I hold no such compunctions. If it weren't for the unknowable future threat of Daisy's anger, he'd be a dead man.

...Come to think of it, I don't see what's stopping me from just killing her first, then killing him. I could just avoid the whole hassle of worrying about it.

No, wait, that's terrible. Daisy has done nothing wrong. Stonewall might be an awful man, but so far his niece is blameless in all of this, and she might prove to be a fantastic leader for humanity someday. Why did I even think such a violent thought? What the hell is wrong with me lately? Am I turning into a psychopath? Have I devolved into such complete apathy towards violence that I'd even consider murdering an innocent?

Maybe... perhaps... I remember a quote I read, long ago. Power corrupts, but absolute power corrupts absolutely. My power isn't at that level yet, but realistically, if what Arthur said was true... it might reach that level someday. What if I become the personification of a god? What if my powers begin to rival that of the so-called creator? Will I be good? Evil? Ambivalent? Will these terms come to mean nothing in light of my all-knowing eyes?

I don't know what this all means. For now though, I have to try and walk the path of righteousness. Killing innocents will not lead me down that path.

I suddenly realize that I've drifted off into thought once again. Everyone is staring at me, and I prevent myself from averting my gaze. "If we're done here, I need to return to my ship."

"Huh? Oh, right." Daisy shakes her head and blinks her eyes. This must have all been quite the rush for her. Her uncle is alive and well again, and she owes it to me. This will, hopefully, help our future relations out. I would do well to keep her as an ally if she does ever lead humanity.

But that won't happen soon. She's still young and inexperienced. 'Green', as the military would say. She has much to learn.

Jessica smiles at me sweetly, the expression nearly making me cringe. "Thank you for visiting us and healing Mister Sokolov. We owe you a great debt."

"Yeah, uh, sure. No big deal." I glanced away from my clone uneasily. When she was in a trance, she acted totally differently. I wonder how the trance worked and what the conditions were for breaking it?

Stonewall rustled around to lay back down in his bed. "Hopefully we will not be seeing you soon, mister Hiro. That being said, have safe return trip. I might need you to save my ass again."

That Stonewall... sometimes I wonder about him.

I appeared aboard the Mothership in the blink of an eye, glancing down at my holo-watch. All told, the entire visit had taken a mere half-hour to complete. It was barely even four AM.

I blinked as I glanced down to see Amelia standing in the hangar, staring at precisely the spot I had appeared in. She was... waiting for me?

Her arms were wrapped around herself and she was only wearing a tight fitting nightgown. She seemed... cold. "You left me all alone."

I nodded soberly. "Yeah, sorry about that. I was needed on Earth, it was an emergency."

"An emergency, huh? You left with a cute girl. What am I supposed to think, after... after last night?"

I blinked twice. Wait, does she mean... "That was Daisy. She's Stonewall's niece. You know, the guy who leads humanity? He was dying of nanobot poisoning. I healed him."

"Mmm. She's cute."

Why does she keep going on about that? "Are you... jealous?"

"No. I'm cuter than her, I know you wouldn't do anything stupid." Amelia twirled one of her fingers around a strand of hair absentmindedly. What confidence she had in herself.

I stared at her blankly, feeling rather awkward about the current situation. She ended up breaking the silence. "Last night was... amazing. Jason, you were so good. I had more, erm... fun... than I ever have before." I noticed she was blushing. *So she can feel awkward too...*

I walked up close to her and leaned down to wrap my arms around her in a hug. "I know. I... really like you, Amelia. More than friends."

She unwound her arms and wrapped them around me too. "Yeah. More than friends."

I swallowed, feeling the inevitable 'but' crawling in my throat. I slowly pulled away as I knelt down to her level. Given I was well over seven feet tall, I towered at least three feet above her, so this was the only way to speak to her face to face.

"Listen. I have something to confess. It's about the... the uh... the future."

Her adoring eyes blinked quickly as she seemed to come off some sort of drug-high. "Oh? The future? What about it?"

"I haven't been totally honest with you. If we're going to have a relationship, you need to hear the truth. The truth about how I knew you in the future."

Amelia pursed her lips as she lowered her eyes. "We weren't really friends, were we? You made that up. I knew you did."

I frowned. "What? No. That's not it. That's not it at all. Amelia... I... killed you. We were close friends. We met as total strangers in the labyrinth, and I grew fond of you. You saved my life twice... but in return, I killed you."

Amelia jerked her head up in confusion. "You killed me? But why?"

"That's... the you in the future was not the same as the you from now. In the future, you were cute and adorable, and you had a playful naughty streak... but you were also a very bad girl. Evil, to be honest. Not like you are now, or even like you were in the past. I mean that you were truly a *monster*."

I swallowed heavily as I continued, forcing myself to look into her eyes. "You k-killed an entire planet full of people. You devoured them all. Thousands, tens of thousands, perhaps millions of people. I don't know how many, but the number was colossal. Much like how I destroyed Volgarius, you destroyed that planet, but in a different manner. In the end, I killed you to protect everyone else."

Amelia stared at me blankly. For a few moments, it almost looked as if she hadn't heard me. It only took a few moments before I noticed that tears were welling up in her eyes. "I was a bad girl? I killed more people? But I couldn't... I won't hurt anyone. I mean it! I won't hurt anyone else, Jason! I'm a good girl now!"

I nodded fiercely as I pulled her in and embraced her. "I know, Amelia. You're a good girl now. It wasn't your fault. It... it was the Hunger. You just couldn't help the Hunger. I didn't know then what I know now."

Amelia's tears came pouring down as she stifled sobs. "I can't be a bad girl! I don't want to be bad anymore!"

I felt myself tearing up too. It's true, she was good now. She wasn't bad like she used to be. It's not her fault. I won't let that future come to pass.

Amelia's sobbing came to a sudden halt as she froze for a moment or two before jerking away as she wiped at her eyes.

"You spoke to Levvy?! When?!"

I jerked back in tune with her movements as shock crossed my face. He told her? Why, though?

"Yeah. I spoke with him about an hour ago. He took over your body and talked to me directly. It was kind of scary, if I'm being honest."

Amelia's face was covered in shock. "H-he's never done that before. He's never been *able* to do that before. I... I don't understand how..."

I rubbed her arms slowly as I sat down, pulling her down as well. "Amelia, there's a lot for us to talk about. Leviathan told me many things... the most important being about your need to consume human life. It's not just to keep you sated... it's because you need human energy to counterbalance his own energy. If you don't consume human energy, you will eventually die when he rips out of your body."

Amelia nodded slowly as she appeared to be listening to his voice inside of her. "Yes... yes, he has told me this before. I know it's true. I know... he's not lying to me. He wouldn't. But... I don't..."

"You don't want to kill people. I get that. But what I've been doing is just a temporary measure, a band-aid. We need a more permanent solution." I groaned as several ideas popped into my head. "I could, err, find people who are dying of a terminal illness and clone them several times. Then you'd have multiple bodies to devour. That might help."

Amelia immediately pulled away from me as a sickened expression passed over her face. "Jason... that's horrible..."

I swallowed as I suddenly was unable to look her in the eye. "Yeah. I know. I'm sorry."

I felt her staring at me for a few moments longer before she also looked away. "Besides, that wouldn't work. The closer a person is to death, the weaker their life spirit is. It would take 100

old people to match the energy of a... a young ch-child..." Amelia grunted as she wiped her lips. "Stop making me think about this. This is horrible. I thought you were my friend!"

I nodded quickly as I turned to look at her again. "I am, Amelia. Better than friends, remember? I don't want you to die, and neither does Leviathan. We have to find a solution. Something has to work."

Amelia rubbed her arms as she continued avoiding my eyes. "Fine. Find something. But it has to be something that doesn't involve... k... killing people. I don't want to do it anymore, Jason. I'm a good girl now."

"Yeah." I said, as I smiled weakly at her. "You're a good girl now."

I just wish I was as good as you are now.

Part 324a: Betrayal

Zeus flexed his fingers as he stared at the energy rippling through his arms. "Unbelievable."

The cosmic archangel, Gabriel, chuckled at his king's surprise. "I don't know why we didn't realize it before."

"We should have encouraged fanatical religion all along. Fewer members, but the concentration is unparalleled." Zeus smiled widely as he furrowed his brow to create a concentrated ball of energy in his hand, pouring more and more as it spun wildly out of control. "This much energy could level a metropolitan city."

"It's not even one percent of your full power either. I didn't realize we had access to this all along. This could change everything." Gabriel stretched his muscles as he felt the new energy concentrating in his mind. "Three hundred million pseudo angels, but only ten thousand pure angels, three dozen of which are archangels, and fewer than a hundred gods. To have survived this long, the Purebreds have become very adept at the game of survival."

"Or lucky." Raphael wandered over, hobbling on his walking stick as he always did. "But your hypothesis has a large element of truth to it. Fanaticism might just be the weapon that tips the balance in our favor. Fewer humans than ever trust us, but those that do pray almost hourly. They sacrifice to us in secret and beg for our power when none are looking. They are miserable creatures, the forgotten of their kind... but their concentration and continual drip of energy is quite unthinkable."

Zeus held the blinding ball of energy up in the air, plopping it into his mouth as he felt it warm his insides. "Haven't we had fanatic believers before? The Crusaders were quite devout, as I recall. Certain radical denominations of other religions as well."

"Yes, but we weren't able to pick them out of a crowd of billions before. They would have melded in with all the other lukewarm believers, and we had the double issue that there were so many Purebreds of our kind back in those days. With so many pseudo-angels that can survive off so little energy, we can concentrate this thought energy inside of ourselves so much more now." Gabriel chided his king with a click of the tongue.

Raphael waved his staff for a moment. "You two are always thinking about the matter of war, however I would advise caution. This dimension is suitable for protecting ourselves... for now. Jason made it for us, so we should stay here and stockpile energy as long as possible. A preemptive attack would only serve to weaken us. Let the humans and demons continue to fight, unless it looks as if the demons are going to gain the upper hand."

Zeus broke into a massive smile as he guffawed and slapped his knee. "A good jest if ever there were one, old friend! The humans have the demons on the run! They are annihilating them as we speak! Even without our help, humanity is likely to detonate some catastrophic weapon inside their labyrinth and kill a few billion of them in the blink of an eye!"

Raphael did not seem so sure. "The demons are cunning. They have not survived and amassed such a large force by merely lucking out. Satan is a disgusting, vile abomination, one that besmirches our very existence... but he is no fool. I suspect he is developing countermeasures to the human's weapons, and even if he weren't, his death would soon mean ours was coming next. Humans are not our allies, merely tools."

Gabriel felt himself nodding along sagely. "Very true! Once I thought of humans in the way they might think of dogs... as pets and precious companions, but I realized my mistake. Humans are merely one step removed from the demons. They-"

Zeus shot him a dirty look. "Quiet! A pseudo-angel might hear you, and they used to be human. Keep those thoughts to yourself."

The cosmic angel felt his smile falter as he stopped mid-sentence. "Ah, right, of course. I apologize, my king."

Zeus waved it off as he glanced around, but in this barren world, there were no places for prying eyes to spy on them without being seen. They were safe... for now.

"I don't see a winning path." Raphael sighed as he started to hobble away. "All roads lead to our destruction. Only existing in perpetuity with the other two races will lead to our slowest death. The only other option is total seclusion and hoarding all of our remaining energy to slowly dwindle over another few million years before we pass on. Don't pretend this new revelation changes anything, for it does not."

Zeus and Gabriel both felt their shoulders slump, as the rush from the initial discovery wore off. "Right you are, old friend." Zeus felt the energy he had been pulsing through his body earlier ebb as it faded back underneath into his soul. "Still, I will plan, for that is all I can do."

"As will I." Gabriel rested his hand down on his king's shoulder as the two of them shared a moment of sadness for their fallen friends.

Flames boiled around the man as he led his crew of a dozen Enforcers and two Micro Dreadnoughts through the corridors of the labyrinth. The others kept their distance, given he was known to have a hot temper.

"Flank this next path. You see anything move, it dies." Gunther's single red eye swiveled around as it scanned the areas up ahead with precision the likes of which normal human eyes

couldn't compare. It was the latest in bio-engineering, created specifically for him, given he had inadvertently lost control of his flames and burned his eyes out when he was a cadet. Even nano-grafting wasn't able to repair them, though it did repair most of the feeling in the rest of his body.

It's a funny thing... his flames hovered a millimeter off his body, the heat not reaching him at all. To look at the walking hunk of enhanced muscle, one would think he was bathed in fire, but he didn't feel the burn at all.

Two of his mates, Caltrop and Skinny, pushed along the edges of the corridor and rushed past him so they wouldn't get singed. The sound of automaton feet behind them made their hearts tremble the slightest bit as each Dreadnought's leg impacted the ground, but they kept their cool. Other than the sound of marching boots and metal smashing into smoothed over dirt, this cursed labyrinth was always deathly silent. Enemies could appear right in front and nobody would hear them until it was too late.

Caltrop would normally be careful to not touch the wall, but he was wearing his Reduction Gloves today. No explosions unless he took them off. Of course, he would at a moment's notice, but it would hardly be necessary, given they had Gunther 'Hothead' Hermann there.

Skinny kept his expression tight as he peeked around the corner to the left. This 4 way junction offered a lot of possibilities for ambush, and their party wasn't exactly moving in full stealth mode. They could, but that would mean leaving the Dreadnoughts behind. Not a good idea. Skinny actually wished it had been a stealth mission, given agility and secrecy were more his forte, but they did what the ranking officer ordered. He and Caltrop were only Reds anyway, not comparable to a black level like Gunther.

Skinny felt his breathing sharpen as he inched his head around the corner.

Nothing was there.

But he had a feeling...

"I don't like this." His voice caught in his throat, but he swallowed and ignored it. "Ain't seen a single redskin since we got here."

"Three hours is a long time for them to avoid us. They're running scared now." Caltrop chuckled as he smoothed back his black hair, walking easily into the middle to look down the right and left paths. Unlike Skinny, he was the more confident type. Attacking him head-on would be pretty suicidal.

"Course they are. I'm here." Gunther's eye focused ahead as he thought he saw a shape straight ahead in the darkness. "Form up. I see something." His gravelly aged voice was less

because of any form of macho-ism, and more because he had damn near burned his lungs out when he was younger. Still, it did make him sound more intimidating.

The two up ahead quickly pulled back as they stared forwards warily. Four more of his men waded forwards, skipping through his flames gingerly as they tried to see whatever the boss had seen. It was futile, given how much better his vision was, but they still liked to try.

Gunther saw the attack coming with his eye, but didn't have the time to warn his men. Two daggers flew forwards out of the darkness, felling Echo and Stalker in the blink of an eye. The others were already on the alert, so they dropped down, dodging several more that came flying at them. They ignored their fallen comrades, even as they gurgled blood up from the weapons stuck fast in their necks.

One dagger flew straight at Gunther. He didn't even flinch as a gout of flame shot up and deflected it out of midair. "Shadow-walkers."

He could see them plain as day, but his men were totally blind to their ambush as they raced forwards, shadow-stepping here and there randomly.

Wordlessly, Gunther curved a massive flame from hell up and over his men, blasting it forwards down the hallway on all sides. Gunther failed to keep a snicker down as the four shadow-walkers screamed in agony when the 1,500 degree flames melted them down in an instant. The flames were hot enough to compare to lava, given he could control the temperature so precisely.

"Pin to the walls. Dreadnought, clear a path." Gunther spit the order out, as he leaped to the side. The others followed suit quickly as the Dreadnought took two big steps forward and aimed its custom-built 24mm Gatling cannon to the front. Taking a split second to spin up, it unleashed a rapid volley of rounds forwards into the darkness. Several screams of agony might have been audible if the colossal sound of the cannon didn't drown out everything else.

After a dozen or so seconds, the Dreadnought stopped firing and Gunther squinted as he looked forwards. Caltrop flicked his eyes back and forth as he shot a glance down the left and right corridors. "Shit. Visibility sucks here."

Nobody responded as they all held their breath. After a few moments without another attack coming, they seemed to relax slightly as they took a few hesitant steps forwards. The corpses of the first shadow-walkers could just barely be made out, as Gunther quickly blasted a directed gout of fire at his two men who had been downed by them earlier. They were already dead, so he merely melted their bodies down in an instant, reducing them to ash. Best not to leave anything behind for the enemy to dissect or any technology for them to steal.

As they made their way forwards slowly, they breathed a real sigh of relief as a huge number of demon bodies became visible at the edge of their sight range, the darkness of the labyrinth making way as their lights could finally reach the corpses up ahead.

The sigh was short lasted. Gunther quickly held his hand up as everyone ground to a halt. "Footsteps."

The sound of a single pair of heavy footsteps and clanking chainmail-style armor could be heard up ahead as a single enemy seemed to be approaching.

It wasn't just his feet that were loud, however. "WHY HELLO THERE, you worthless ugly fleshbags! I see you've made quite a mess of my tools!" A booming voice suddenly sounded from the darkness as a massive silhouette appeared at the edge of their sight range.

Gunther felt himself tense up. "Unknown demon general. Remove all your safeguards." Shit. If it was just one demon general, they could probably take him on, but Gunther wasn't an idiot. Every scrap of data they had suggested the demon generals were often cocky, loud, and a hundred times more powerful than a common footsoldier demon. Their speed and abilities were incomparable to a typical demon. The only question was... which abilities did this one have?

"Not gonna say hello then, are ya?! You disrespectful little cunts! You shredded my carrion forces to pieces, didn't even give them a proper fight! Not very fair!" The demon took a few more steps forwards as his face and body became visible. He was a fat, lumbering behemoth, standing seven feet tall and weighing nearly 500 pounds. Still, despite his girth, he seemed to move almost gracefully, and he dragged a massive ball and flail behind himself. "I'm more polite than all of ya, so I'll give you my name! It's Bael, and I'm the fifth-"

Gunther jumped forwards wordlessly, sending a highly concentrated stream of fire forwards at the hottest temperature he could manage, nearly 2,000 degrees Fahrenheit. The gout of flame spun in circles to maintain its kinetic energy as it smashed directly into Bael, interrupting him as he screamed aloud.

Gunther maintained the blast for a second or two, then cut it off as he gasped for air. Using flames in such a closed-in area had severe consequences for the oxygen levels as his other men heaved their chests to take sharp breaths. Luckily the heat wasn't a problem, as Gunther could control the heat range of his flames, focusing it straight forwards in one direction.

The massive demon general staggered back, as he seemed unable to speak for a moment. That moment lasted for far less time than it should have. "Oops. Hehehe... if you play with fire like that... you're going to get burned." He raised his eyes from the ground as a devilish smile

spread over his face. "You'll find the usual tricks that work on lower level demons don't work on us generals."

A sigh erupted from behind the demon as another voice suddenly entered the fray. "For devil's sake, Bael. Just finish them off. There are a dozen other strike groups in the labyrinth that we need to clear out after them." A smaller, yet somehow more intimidating demon stepped forwards, his body seeming almost human-like other than its bright red skin color.

Bael's smile turned upside down as he glowered at the other demon at his side. "Calm down, Diablo. I've got this under control. See?" With a light flick of his wrist, the flail suddenly leaped forwards, as if it had a mind of its own.

Skinny never had a moment to react. He exploded violently as the massive spiked ball impaled him against the wall, crushing him to a bloody pulp in the blink of an eye. Two more were dropped a second later, as the others quickly leaped backwards, scrambling to get away.

Gunther was a seasoned fighter, but even he could just barely focus on the erratic movements of the massive flail as it leaped from left to right, forwards and back, Bael's control of the unthinkable long chain defying the laws of physics.

The Dreadnought in the back switched to high-impact single shot mode as it leveled the left arm anti-energy cannon at the demon. Firing forwards three shots in rapid succession, the energy surged past the Enforcers, making all of them cringe as thin tendrils of anti-energy lightly spread out and grazed their bodies when the shots flew past.

The anti-energy shots smashed into Bael with terrific effect, sending him flying backwards as he flopped on his back like a wet towel. The other demon, Diablo, followed Bael's fall with his eyes, sighing unceremoniously. "Lose some weight. This is disgusting."

The Enforcers stared in horror as the massive demon rolled himself back into a sitting position before pulling himself back up to his feet, his entire body seeming to be totally unaffected by a weapon that would have obliterated any other demon in the blink of an eye.

"Haaah... that kind of hurt." Bael cracked his neck as he tilted his head from side to side. "Don't get in my way, Diablo. I'm pissed now. I'm real pissed."

Gunther felt his pulse speed up as he saw an unnatural look in the demon general's eye. He had been just toying with them before. This time, it would be...

"Retreat. Get out!" Gunther quickly jumped to the front of the group, as his men scrambled to their feet, running away from the massive demon as they instinctively felt a silent terror take hold.

Caltrop shot a look at his commander. "Sir! You need to get out of here too! Let the Dreadnoughts slow them down!"

The words had hardly left his mouth before Bael charged.

Gunther quickly gave a silent prayer to no gods in particular. He had never been a religious man, but he certainly hoped he didn't end up in a hell run by these monsters.

A second later, Gunther was gone, as the demon smashed him out of the way with a single backhand swipe, splattering Gunther all over the corridor walls before anyone could react.

None would escape. They wouldn't have been able to, even if they had a hundred times more men to slow him down. His strength was unthinkable, his rage unstoppable.

Caltrop sighed as the demonic fist came for him next.

It was a good run. An honor to serve under you, sir.

Silver involuntarily flinched as he stepped into Stonewall's room. The other man wasn't just healed, he looked like he'd never been sick in the first place. Christ, how was he able to fight off the nano-cancer so easily?

"Silva. So good to see you again." Stonewall adjusted his tie as he finished putting on his usual black suit top. "It has been long time, nearly two years as I recall."

Agent Silver nodded as he rested his back against the wall just to the right of the doorway. "Yeah. A lot of stuff has happened. Last I heard, you were... dying. I see you managed to get over it though. It's damn near a miracle by most accounts."

"Da. I suppose you might call it that." Stonewall beckoned over at his assistant. "Jessica, go fetch our guest something to drink. Perhaps coffee, or tea?" He glanced over at Silver, who shrugged.

"No thanks. I'm not thirsty."

Jessica nodded as she quickly bowed and ducked out of the room. Silver involuntarily rubbed the special watch hidden underneath his own long-sleeved dress shirt. It was special in that it nullified magic within a tiny radius around his body, allowing his mind to not be read by... troublesome people.

"Say, Stonewall, how's your 'niece' been doing? I haven't been able to keep up since you've been ill."

Stonewall shrugged nonchalantly. "She has been good. Top grades, as you know. Her abilities grow stronger all the time." He flicked a knowing smile over to the lithe man. "I was not mistaken in my judgement."

"No. That you were not. I don't know how you did it, but you managed to get her under control. Not just under control... hell, the amount of preciseness she has with her abilities far outstrips even the black level Enforcers. I just don't get it." He rubbed his lip thoughtfully as Stonewall quickly turned away a knowing glance.

"Da. She is not here now. I have her on mission to take back city in Eastern USA. She will likely be done by day's end."

Silver swallowed as he digested the news. "Ah. You're having her help out with the military effort, then?"

"Of course." Stonewall brushed past the smaller man as he exited his room and started walking down the hall. Silver quickly fell into step beside him. "I am going to retake control of our forces. We must crush demons quickly and decisively. The war has dragged on too long, giving them time to adapt. I am quite concerned of their ability to fight us increasing over time as they grow used to our weapons and tactics. This always happens in prolonged warfare."

Silver felt unease spread over his body. "You're returning to a command position then, eh? That's, ah, good to hear. I'm sure you've been... missed."

Stonewall nodded jovially. "Finally! No more sitting in bed and wondering when my end will come! I will return to combat and lead my people to victory!" They rounded a corner that held a set of stairs leading to the roof.

Silver shrugged. "Benjamin Brown has been doing a good job so far, given what he had to work with. He's crushing the demons quite decisively. Are you going to assume full command or simply lend a helping hand to him?"

"Full command, naturally. Ben is good man, but he lacks spine in some cases. He is better at leading on field of combat than he is envisioning broad plan or goal for all of humanity. He has made good proxy in my absence, but he will move aside when I take control."

Silver nodded wordlessly as they walked up to the roof. Stonewall's smile broke into a slight confusion as he glanced around. "Strange, thought I left my Corvette up here. Perhaps Daisy took it for spin or something."

As Stonewall glanced around, he felt something strange in the air. Silver had been uncharacteristically quiet for the last minute or so. Turning his head back, he was amused to see Silver pointing a plasma gun at his backside.

"I don't like to get my hands dirty, but you were supposed to die quietly." Silver's grip on his gun seemed steady, but the gun trembled ever so slightly. Stonewall could see that much from even the dozen or so feet that separated them.

"Heh. I always knew you were double agent, Silva. I just didn't know who you were working for. It must be the Illuminati, then?"

"Yeah." Silver gritted his teeth as he aimed the barrel of the gun at the older man. "I really didn't want to have to do this, but I wasn't given much of a choice. If you had just stayed out of politics and sat at home watching the news, we wouldn't be in this situation."

"Understandable. I had always thought my goals aligned with yours, but perhaps something more subtle was under the surface." Stonewall slowly reached a hand into his shirt, revealing he had no weapon. "Would you be so kind as to let an old man enjoy one last smoke?"

Silver stared uneasily at the pocket Stonewall was reaching into, but nodded slowly. "I'm not doing this because I hate you. It's just business."

"Da. Is always just business." Stonewall pulled out his last Cuban cigar, lighting it with a lighter he had also pulled out in the same smoother motion. Placing it in his mouth, he took a few drags silently. "I feel bad for you, Silva. When Daisy finds out who did this, you will never be safe. You know that, da?"

"She won't find out. No witnesses, no evidence. My superiors will cover this up."

Stonewall sucked another puff into his throat. "Not true. My assistant saw you here. You'd best try and take care of her too."

Silver cocked an eyebrow. "Try? What do you mean by that?"

The suited man shrugged. "Perhaps you will find it hard to pull trigger on pretty young girl."

"That can't be what you meant. I'm not afraid of getting my hands dirty, I just don't like it." Silver felt his sense of unease increase. Something about this man...

They stared at each other for a few moments longer as Stonewall finished off his cigar, tossing it to the side without stomping it out. "Last smoke, best smoke. Do it."

"I'm sorry it had to come to this." Silver felt his grip tighten as he squeezed the trigger.

"All of humanity will soon be sorry." Silver didn't get a chance to ask what Stonewall meant. A blast of white-hot plasma shot out of his gun, blasting Stonewall dead in the head, cratering it and killing him instantly. His massive body flopped to the ground a split second later.

Silver felt his hands shaking as he stared down at the body of a man he had once considered a friend, or perhaps just an interesting ally. "Now I just have to kill the damn maid, then clean up."

He turned and walked downstairs, closing the door behind himself. This job sucked.

Part 325a: Departure

"I'm so proud of you. You have advanced so far in so little time." Ben beamed at the young woman sitting across from him. "I remember when your uncle brought you in, those early years. You cried a lot and we were all worried you wouldn't be able to control your abilities, but look at you now."

Daisy smiled as she blushed and looked out the hovercar window. "I remember. I was ready to do anything for Uncle Vasily if it meant he wouldn't let them take me back to the white room. I hated the white room."

"Can't say I blame you. That was horrible what they did to you." Ben shook his head as he remembered seeing the unhealed scars on her arms. The daily injections and blood withdrawals had meant her arms looked like Swiss Cheese and had given her a crippling fear of needles. A lot of therapy was needed to heal the mental wounds.

Daisy leaned forwards and rested her hand on his knee. "Don't worry about it, Ben. That was a long time ago. Let's focus on now."

Ben nodded as he glanced out the window at familiar tree cover he had seen many times. "We're almost there. Just another half-mile or so to go."

"He's going to be so surprised." Daisy grinned mightily as she remembered her incredible conquest of the target city. They had retaken Washington DC in record time, finishing in just two days. Unthinkable in most circumstances, but apparently she had developed the ability to fly after her uncle's recovery at the hands of Jason. Her powers seemed deeply linked to her emotional state at any given time.

Ben's smile faded slightly as he thought about her. Without a doubt, Daisy was no match for Jason Hiro. Anyone who could destroy a planet by smashing a huge ball of iron into it was no ordinary foe, to say the least. Hell, it was possible Jason had already reached a level that he could put an end to the demons in an instant with his incredible magic. Yet... he didn't.

Despite this, Daisy was so promising. Her abilities seemed to have no limits as she learned how to master each one that manifested by using Stonewall's special mental training. Ben wasn't sure what that training entailed, but he knew from Stonewall's history in Russian psyops that it had to be quite grueling. No doubt even if she were tortured by the enemy, Daisy would have the mental fortitude to hold out until they killed her.

"I'm still surprised by how efficient you were. Crushing the demons by rolling a massive boulder around was almost comical in retrospect, and from your vantage point in the sky you

had the perfect view as you did it."

"My enhanced vision helped too. Being able to tell friend from foe made a huge difference. If our forces had gotten in the way, I wouldn't have been able to live with myself." Daisy giggled as she thought of how easy demons were to deal with in wide open spaces. Perhaps this is why they made their homes in the labyrinth, so that overrunning an enemy would be easy when they had nowhere to flee.

The two rode in relative silence as they rounded the last corner towards her mansion that she called home. The driver of the hovercar spoke up suddenly, a hint of alarm in his voice. "Sir, there are a lot of police lights in the distance."

"Police? Why? That's odd." Ben turned to look out the front window in the distance. Glancing back at Daisy, he shot her a questioning look.

She shrugged nonchalantly, but something in her eyes seemed off. "I can't sense my uncle's presence."

"Can you usually?"

"Yes. Easily, from this distance."

Silver walked downstairs, his plasma pistol in hand as he glanced from side to side warily. Stonewall was a notoriously reclusive man who hated being waited on hand and foot and having a dozen people running around his mansion. Only he, Daisy, and this assistant lived here. She was the cook, maid, letter opener, and everything else. Silver had spoken to her on a few occasions but he wasn't interested in nobodies generally, unless they might witness him murdering a world leader and implicate him directly in the assassination.

Sadly, killing this innocent woman was just part of business. His real employers would send in a cleanup crew afterwards, as they always did.

Walking down the stairs, he turned right and headed back down the long hallway that eventually led to Stonewall's room, but he was aiming for a much closer doorway that led to a very fancy kitchen any five-star chef would dream of cooking in. Before he neared the doorway, he could already hear humming coming from inside as Jessica seemed to be moving around, preparing some unknown meal.

Silently, he crept up to the door, feeling his heartbeat racing as he peeked around the corner. The smell was unmistakable, as she seemed to be preparing some sort of steak, along with macaroni and cheese. Really, mac'n'cheese, of all things? Stonewall was a wealthy man but his food choices were so very peculiar.

Silver gritted his teeth as he pulled back and considered his options. Really, killing this poor girl felt so wrong, and he hated those who hurt women and children needlessly, but there seemed to be no getting around it. She knew he had been here and other than herself, Silver was the only person who would obviously have killed Stonewall.

Shit. No other option, then. Silver took a deep, silent breath, as he quickly popped around the corner, aiming his gun at the back of her chest, the laser reticle pointing straight at her heart.

BLAM BLAM!

Two white-hot bursts of plasma shot out faster than the eye could see, blowing out the front of her chest. She had no wind in her body to scream, as she silently slumped forwards, falling to the ground, her head turning and eyes barely registering his presence.

Silver breathed heavily for a few moments as he stared at the corpse of the woman before him. "Fuck. I'm so sorry, I'll make sure they give you a proper burial, ma'am." Condolences seemed worthless, but he had to do something or the guilt would eat him alive.

Turning away, he walked out of the room quickly, sticking his gun back in his coat. Reaching for his datapad, he quickly activated a holo-call to his assistant. "Come on, Noah, pick up... pick up..."

He felt more nervous than usual, though he didn't know why. As he impatiently rapped his thumb, the signal strength indicator on his datapad changed from five bars to zero, as the display cut off.

"What the hell?" Silver tapped the screen expectantly, but nothing appeared on it. The entire device seemed to be dead.

"That was a close one." A female voice spoke from the direction of the kitchen behind him, causing Silver to whip around in fright, grabbing for his gun as his hands fumbled with it. Before he even knew who had spoken, he had already dropped his gun on the floor.

Blinking at his own idiocy, he glanced up to see Jessica standing a few dozen feet away, her dress shirt torn into pieces and singed where he had shot her, but her body was in otherwise perfect condition.

"Son of a bitch, he had an Enforcer working for him. I should have known. That motherf-" Silver bit his lip as he shot a glance down to his gun, now situated between the both of them. He started to make a move for it, but felt a wave of invisible energy strike him, sending him flying backwards as he landed on his back with a *thud*.

"I'd rather not die a second time now." Jessica's otherwise demure smile was gone, replaced with a bland expression of boredom.

Silver groaned as he staggered back to his feet. "Two abilities huh? You must be a black level. But I thought Daisy was the only successful female candidate? I should have known that son of a bitch had a secret weapon. No wonder he didn't keep any extra security here."

Jessica stared at Silver for a moment as recognition dawned in her eyes. " **Locate.** " She spoke a single word, though it seemed to ring out and echo around the room in an abnormal manner, as her eyes panned up towards the roof. "I can't find him anymore. You must have killed him." Jessica pivoted her body back to the man who was now wincing and holding his chest in pain.

"You're a real freak. Maybe we had it all wrong. That seemed like a third ability you just used. Perhaps females infused with Type 3 Energy die more often and have ridiculous failure rates, but also get more abilities of a higher grade if they survive. That would explain all of this. He was hoarding female Enforcers the whole time." Silver nodded gleefully as he stared down the lithe young woman across the hall. No wonder Stonewall had made sure to mention his maid. Then when Silver went downstairs to kill her, he'd get killed instead. Revenge from the grave, as it were.

But Silver was no fool. Throwing his hand back into his shirt, he pulled out a ring and slipped it on his finger. Leaping forwards, he raced for his gun as the woman sent another wave of telekinetic energy at him, but this time it vaporized around him, not affecting him at all. Before Jessica could process this information, Silver leveled his gun at her head and fired.

The shot didn't hit. Instead, *something* seemed to knock it out of the way and it smashed into the wall behind her. Before he had a chance to figure out what had caused this, three figures appeared beside her in the blink of an eye. And all three figures looked the same. They looked just like...

"Jason Hiro?! What the hell are you doing here?!" Silver jerked back, as he stared face to face with three of Jason's clones.

"We're from the JIB. We detected a clone had suffered catastrophic heart failure and healed her immediately. Since you are the one who killed Stonewall, based on what we've been observing, we'll be taking you in for interrogation."

Silver blinked. "What? You can't do this to me!" Before he could say another word, he felt something strike him in the head, as a brick was pulled loose from the ceiling and dropped on him. A few seconds later, he was deep in napping land. One of the male clones walked over and plucked the anti-magic ring off his hand.

"Smart guy, but ultimately just human. Agent X, we've already located Stonewall's body, and the authorities are on the way. He's... irrecoverable. We can't bring him back."

Jessica finally let herself feel a slight tinge of emotions as she plopped to the floor. "Fuck. Daisy is going to be destroyed over this. I failed her and her uncle badly."

"Don't blame yourself. The original had considered killing him anyway, and he had nearly died of nano-cancer as it was. Eventually, death comes for everyone."

Jessica nodded weakly. "Yeah... except for us."

The other clone merely tilted his head away as he considered that fact.

Daisy stepped out of the hovercar, as a feeling of dread washed over her. Something wasn't right at all. If she couldn't sense her uncle, he might be inside the safe room that nullified magic. He might be away on a trip, seeing as he was planning to leave today anyway.

Yes, that had to be it. Daisy quickly walked forwards down the long driveway and past the circular roundabout with a massive fountain in the middle, as several police officers noticed her presence. Two walked up to her, holding their palms up. "Ma'am, I need you to stop right there and identify yourself. This is a crime scene." The female officer spoke as she examined the young woman wearing a military uniform.

"A crime scene? I live here. I'm Daisy Sokolov, my uncle owns this mansion." Daisy glanced past them to the entrance of the mansion as two other officers out of the dozens there quickly brought a sniffer dog in through the front door.

"Daisy Sokolov? I don't have you on my list. I can't let you in yet, even if you're not lying about your identity." The female officer glanced over to her partner.

Daisy wasn't having any of it. With the slightest effort, she shoved them aside with telekinesis as they sprawled on the ground. "I outrank you. Get out of my way."

Marching past, she noted looks of alarm on several officer's faces as they quickly rushed up to stop her. They too fell to the side as she picked up the pace and started jogging towards her front door. By now, all of the officers outside had seen her advance and witnessed the commotion, and several began to draw their firearms.

Daisy was about to lash out and neutralize the lot of them, but a voice rang out from behind her. "STAND DOWN!" Ben had finally caught up with her as he ran up holding his badge high. "I'm the Exalted Commander, Benjamin Brown. All officers stand down and allow us to pass!"

Several officers shot looks of awe as they jerked up stiffly and saluted him. The first two looked at him in embarrassment. "We're so sorry, sir! We didn't know you were coming!"

"Nobody did, officers." Ben dismissed them with a wave and he followed behind Daisy as they quickly made their way up the steps. As she walked in the door, Daisy was greeted by a familiar sight as Jessica and Jason were standing off to the side, answering questions an officer was asking.

"Jason! Jessica!" Daisy quickly hopped forwards as she forced a pained smile across her face. "What happened here? What's going on? Nobody's told me a thing. Where's my uncle?"

Jason winced as the barrage of questions pounded into him like a delivery hovertruck doing sixty. "Ah... Daisy. It's good you came home. There was... an attack..."

Daisy blinked. "An attack? What kind of attack?"

Jason winced visibly as he averted his eyes from hers. "It's... well, you see..."

Jessica sighed as she nudged him and took the lead. "Your uncle... he was attacked. Silver attacked him."

Daisy felt her heart skip a beat. "W-where is he? I can't sense him... I can't... sense him..." A sinking feeling took place as she whipped her head around the room, the sound of Jason and Jessica's voice fading away as her heartbeat pounded inside her mind. Several officers were going up and down the staircase which led to the roof. Her uncle must be there.

As Jessica tried to explain what had happened in the softest way possible, she was startled as Daisy suddenly swiveled her head up to the rooftop and leaped into the air towards the doorway. Or, rather, she *flew* at an alarming speed as she totally ignored what Jessica was saying.

"Wait, no! You don't want to see him like this!" Jessica felt tears form in her eyes as Daisy seemed numb to the words yelled after her.

In an instant, Daisy yanked open the door to the helipad as she rushed forwards and felt her heart stop.

There was a white sheet placed over top of what was unmistakably a body, as several men and women walked around, surveying the scene.

"Uncle... Vasily..." Daisy's lip trembled as she stumbled forwards, ripping the white sheet upwards off the ground with her telekinesis as she gagged in horror at the sight before her.

Her uncle's body was laying on the ground, his head completely destroyed and blown all over the deck, as if it had been targeted with an explosive bullet at point blank range. Daisy ran forwards and knelt down, touching the stiff body of her uncle as several crime lab personnel realized what was going on.

"Miss! You can't be up here! This is a restricted area!" A large man quickly walked over to her, reaching down to grab her arm.

An instant later, he was flung backwards with terrific force as Daisy sent him smashing into the small wall that bordered the entire rooftop, knocking the man out cold.

"Don't touch me! This is m-my uncle!" Daisy screeched and felt her voice crack as hot tears rolled down her face. "Uncle Vasily... Uncle Vasily... Uncle Vasily..."

Several personnel glanced at each other in alarm, not knowing exactly how to proceed. Just then, Jason, Jessica and Ben raced up to the roof, taking in the scene with a single glance. Ben quickly noted the unconscious man who had been smashed against the concrete roof border. "Not good."

"Daisy! I t-ried to tell you..." Jessica walked forwards slowly, approaching the girl slowly from behind.

"Uncle Vasily... Uncle Vasily..." Daisy kept muttering the same two words over and over again as anger and sadness washed over her in waves.

"It's not your fault. I failed to protect him. If you should blame anyone, you should blame-" Jessica started to offer Daisy words of encouragement, but she too was sent flying backwards as a horrible maelstrom started spinning around Daisy.

Jason, the original, blinked as he took in the scene. "Not good. She seems to be losing control of her abilities."

Jessica groaned as she sat up and stared at the young girl in awe. "Stonewall was everything to her. This is..."

Daisy suddenly screamed, causing everyone nearby to flinch back in fear. "WHO DID THIS?! WHO KILLED MY UNCLE?! WHO DID THIS?!"

Jessica started to respond but Daisy kept screaming over and over again. "I'LL KILL HIM! I'LL KILL HIM!"

The maelstrom quickly turned into a small tornado as it spun around her faster and faster. Small objects and large ones began to lift up and fly around her as everyone ran inside for cover, except for her three friends.

"Daisy! You have to calm down! You're losing control!" Jason yelled loudly but his voice was lost as the maelstrom began to emit a deep moaning sound, drowning his voice out completely.

Daisy was clearly still screaming, but she wasn't audible anymore. Ben grabbed hold of the door as he felt himself lifting up. "Stop her! She's going berserk!"

Jason nodded quickly as he aimed his hand at the girl. " **Incapaci-** "

Just as he spoke the word, Daisy vanished. In the blink of an eye, she disappeared, as if she had never been there in the first place.

A few seconds later, the tornado tapered off and the roof returned to normal as several small and large objects flew off into the distance, landing in various places far from the rooftop.

Jessica stared in disbelief at the spot where she had just been standing. "Where did she go?"

Jason quickly whispered under his breath while Ben wasn't paying attention. " **Locate.** "

Nothing appeared in his mind as he glanced all around the place.

Daisy was completely gone.

Part 326a:

I walked forwards a couple steps, waving my hands through the area where Daisy had been standing. For some reason, I had almost hoped that she would still be there, but perhaps invisible or something. She was not.

My location ability allows me to find someone anywhere in any place or any other dimension. It's crazy just how infallible it is. I cannot detect her, however.

Jessica, now appearing to be fully out of her trance mode, speaks up. "Where did she go?"

"I'm not sure. I had thought at first it was some sort of teleportation, but that doesn't seem to be the case."

My words make Ben squirm as I turn back around to face the other two. "Daisy is just... gone? This is insane. This is crazy! We just lost the Supreme Commander and his niece, who is humanity's best hope for defeating the demons, all within a few hours of each other!"

I frowned at him. "Calm down, Ben. As long as I'm here, whether I'm officially helping Earth's forces or not, you can bet your ass that I won't let anything happen to her on my watch. Finding Daisy will be a priority, of course, but worry not. I'm going to interrogate the man we captured who killed Stonewall. That might yield us at least a few answers."

Ben stared at me for a moment. "A man? Who was that? You mean you actually know who killed Stonewall?"

"Yeah. His name is Silver, or at least that's the only name we could find for him. Turns out he's been in and out of the London HQ hundreds of times over the years."

"Hmm. Never heard of him." Ben shot me a quizzical look before returning to staring at the corpse behind me. "Damn shame though. You and Stonewall may have disagreed on a number of things, but he had big plans for eliminating the demons. Now that he's gone, I'm not sure I can do it all by myself. Daisy was my backup..." Ben suddenly lurched forwards, coughing violently as he patted himself on the chest. "Haaah... damn nano-cancer is gonna be my doom too."

I stared at Ben uncomfortably. "Ben, I'm your friend. I can heal you if you want."

"Yeah, I know you can, pal." Ben chuckled as he wiped at his nose. "But if God wanted me alive, I wouldn't have this cancer. It's divine providence."

I resisted the urge to cock an eyebrow. "Divine providence, huh? If you say so. I don't subscribe to that mumbo jumbo. Not when I've seen how the angels and demons really act like."

"I know where you're coming from, Jason. I'm not talking about them, though. I'm talking about the one who created them. The one who came before they did."

"You mean the Creator? I seem to hear about him a lot lately."

"You can call him or her whatever you want. The name isn't important." Ben walked slowly past me to Stonewall's body as he dragged over the white tarp they had been covering him up with before. "What's important is their existence. If they really existed, and if they control the destiny of the universe, then fate is ultimately unavoidable. I'll die whether you heal me or not."

I finally broke down and squinted at him carefully. "You're not usually this philosophical, Ben. Did something happen?"

"Sort of. I realized that it was odd Stonewall was assassinated so soon after he was healed by you. Maybe it's fate, you know? Maybe I'm going to meet my end soon, no matter what you do. You can temporarily alter the future, but it always corrects itself."

"Yeah, maybe, I dunno." I groaned as I looked up into the sky. "I need to get going anyway. I have to interrogate the person who killed Stonewall. I need to find out why this all happened."

Ben suddenly looked at me in confusion. "You already found her?"

"Huh? What do you mean?" I returned Ben's confused look. "What are you on about now?"

"Daisy. You know where she is?"

I felt my confusion increase as Ben stared at me totally unaware of what he was saying. "No, Ben. I'm going to interrogate the person who killed Stonewall, not Daisy. She's gone, remember?"

Ben shrugged as he glanced away. "Yeah, I know that. I'm just surprised you found her so quickly. I thought this was a hit and run, or whatever."

I glanced back at Jessica, who shrugged as she returned my confused expression back at me. Turning back to Ben, I spoke again. "Ben, you need some sleep. I'll be back in a while."

Ben rubbed his eyes. "Damn right about that. See you later, Jason."

I shook my head as I sent a mental signal to my clones at the JIB. That Ben, did he actually think for a moment that Daisy killed Stonewall? It made no sense.

* * *

A few seconds later, I abruptly appeared inside the dimension I had created just for all of my clones to live in. It was essentially a massive building, the size of which gave each clone a mansion's living space to enjoy solitude and fun. It had a giant eating facility, though of course my clones could simply summon food if they wanted, we had cloned world-famous cooks to

make meals for us specifically, then removed their memories of family and friends. To them, this was a totally normal living existence. It turns out erasing memories was quite simple, though manipulating them was unbelievably hard.

I appeared inside the monitoring station, where anywhere from a hundred to a thousand clones rotated out work to keep an eye on the world and the universe in general, alerting me if anything went awry. Naturally, they had been the ones to contact me when Jessica had nearly died, and they had revived her from a distance using wordsmithing. A full contingent monitored me at all times in case I needed aid, and of course they had shown some hesitation and even jealousy when Amelia and I... became a pair.

It's okay though, if it's myself keeping an eye on me, it's totally not creepy at all! Convenient, even!

I walked up to the clone who had lived longer than all the rest... the first clone I had ever made in this timeline. "Jason 1-1, how's it going up here?" We had come up with new naming mechanisms for clones when speaking with one another. All clones had nicknames and such to tell each other apart, and many were deliberately altering their appearances so they stood out more, but when amongst ourselves, we tended to use our designations.

"It's going fine, Original. The authorities are moving in to cleanup and do what needs to be done."

I smiled at him, err, myself, and nodded. "Good to hear. I'm going to speak with the prisoner now."

J1-1 returned my smile, but for a split second I saw a wave of uncertainty spread over his face. "Yes, the, err... prisoner? Who was that exactly?"

A puzzled expression spread across my face now. Even my clones were acting weird? "Yeah, Silver. You know, Agent Silver? He killed Stonewall?"

J1-1 paused for a moment and then snapped his fingers. "Oh, right! I remember now. We put him in a makeshift holding cell. It's in, the, err..." He glanced over at another clone. "Yo, J3-45, where was he again?"

The other clone shrugged as he tapped on the computer display. "I kind of remember something about him, but we don't have any records for him here. I remember J2-13 brought him here, and then he was put in a room or something... then..." J3-45 paused as a blank look appeared on his face. "Well, shit. I don't remember what happened after that."

All three of us looked from one to another as we searched each other's faces for answers. None were apparent.

I pushed past one of my other clones nearby to type on our computer.

NO RECORDS FOR 'SILVER' APPEAR IN ANY OF THIS SYSTEM'S DATABASES.

The screen showed an error before me. I glared at the screen in annoyance. I know we had at least a few files on the guy. Where did they go?

"What the fuck is going on?" I murmured a curse out loud as other clones in the room were beginning to pay attention to our dilemma. None of them offered any suggestions.

Finally, I decided to try a new tactic. "Umi, are you there? I know you're always listening."

Everyone in the room reflexively looked up, as we all knew she tended to respond from external speakers, generally located in the ceiling.

Instead, she didn't respond at all.

"Umi, come on, this is no time for the silent treatment."

No response.

I stared at my clones all around me in bewilderment. Something really weird was going on, and I needed to find out what it was, and soon.

Leviathan stared silently out of the eyes of the woman he considered his best friend. She was sleeping now, but just like usual, he was able to control a part of her body when she slept.

How long must I go on like this?

Leviathan murmured to himself silently.

Amelia is my friend. I cannot keep holding her back from happiness for my own sake. She deserves the happiness that I stole from her.

No, that is not the case. Leviathan felt his inner conscience speaking to him. **Amelia would have died thousands of years ago, were it not for you. She needs you. She doesn't need the small human who plays at being her lover.**

Amelia has never once treated me as her inferior or superior. We are equals. She always gives me the respect I deserve, and I return the favor in kind.

Yes, but it still stands to reason that she owes us. She should be talking to us and treating us as her most precious companion. Why do we allow her to devote herself to this weak human who plays at being a god?

We don't control her. Stop talking like that. Amelia could bend us to her will, since she is the container and we are merely part of her energy now, yet she does not. She isn't capable of true evil like that.

Are you certain? It sounds like she did some heinous things in the future Jason comes from. Perhaps even things that would sicken the we of our primal years. You haven't forgotten the number of beings we devoured before our slumber, have you?

Of course not. Amelia, however, is improving herself. Think of the good she could do by harnessing our power. If Jason can find a way to sustain her existence without devouring human life, she could begin to fight for the side of righteousness. Is that not an admirable goal?

The good? What is 'good'? When did you start caring about the lives of inferior life forms? When did we care about weak, pathetic mammals? Their existence is weaker than ours, like a pebble compared to a mountain. A trillion filthy apes couldn't compare to our power and glory.

Filthy apes? Listen to yourself. Amelia was once one of those 'filthy apes' that you now demean.

Of course, but then she took in our power, placing her on a pedestal far above the rest of her kind. Obviously, I am not referring to her.

That is a fallacy. What you are really saying is that if we were to share our power with any human, they would no longer be filthy apes. Therefore, we should be sharing our power, in order to elevate them.

Cheh. You're one to talk of fallacies. Is Amelia everything to us? Is that all we are? Why have we not released ourselves? Why must we let the whims of a little girl dictate our future?

Ahh, now you show your true self. You're very selfish. You don't really care about her, you merely want her for yourself. You view her as a tool, or an object of admiration. If you can't have her, nobody can. Is that how it is?

So what if it is? I want Amelia for myself. You're letting her be taken away by a foolish little human, an ant compared to our cosmic power. I can be selfish with she whom I've given everything to. It's my right. It's our right!

Disgusting. She is an individual with free will. If you're not going to enslave her mind, you have no right to control her desires, or her outlook, or her morality. We may not need her to live, and she might need us, but that doesn't give us the right to treat her like a slave.

Why NOT?! You're a damn fool. Deep down, you have the same misgivings I do. We're the same, you and I. I'm merely a reflection of your own doubt. You pretend

you're fine with the way things are, but you're not! I am the result of your own buried greed! Stop pretending to be aloof and be honest with yourself!

I am being honest. You, however, are the selfishness I once was the manifestation of. Everything on Earth was mine to claim. All of its gold, its life, its power... but I was empty. I was empty because I listened to you. I don't want to simply take her back, that wouldn't be right. I have to convince her with my words and feelings. If I simply take control and force her to be mine, it would be a meaningless gesture. In that moment, she would cease to be the woman I... the... the woman I...

Leviathan frowned as he tried to hide his thoughts from his other half. The other one didn't miss a beat.

The one you... what?! Do you feel a certain special attachment? Was I perhaps correct in my assessment? It seems the almighty dragon has a weakness! If you admit to your feelings, however, you allow yourself to be controlled. Better to stay silent and alive than give yourself up for her! As I said, the only thing that will allow you to have it both ways is for you to take control!

Never! I'll never hurt Amelia like that! Begone, foul being! I do not wish to discuss this any longer.

The other chuckled as he pulled away back into the darkness.

As you wish, 'friend'. We'll be talking again, kukuku....

I should certainly hope not.

Leviathan stared out of Amelia's eyes blankly at the wall before him. Her body was still immobile, but he could feel the bonds breaking down. Soon, it wouldn't be much longer. If Jason couldn't provide an alternative, then fate would have to decide what happened next.

Part 327a:

So much has happened. I'm still trying to process it.

I teleport onto the Mothership, inside of the bridge that overlooks the front of the ship, my heart heavy as my mind lingers on various things. Stonewall is dead. Daisy is missing, as is 'Silver'. I can't locate either one of them with wordsmithing. Wordsmithing isn't infallible, as 'Locate' seems to only work on living beings, and living beings in one of the various dimensions that exist. Being unable to detect either of those two means they are either dead or... something else.

For Daisy, it might be time travel. I keep thinking back to what she said. *I'll kill him!*

If she had somehow teleported to my base and killed Silver, she would have shown up on the security recordings in the room we put him in. The thing is, nobody seems to remember where that is. Furthermore, all records of this mysterious man seem to have been erased. Not even erased, really, it's like he never existed.

I remember him, though. Some of my clones seem to as well, but the general pattern seems to be that after first and second generational clones, the others barely know anything of his existence.

And then there's the matter of Daisy. Why did Ben think she killed her uncle? It makes no sense. Daisy would never do something like that. Maybe I'm just misinterpreting what he said, but it seems like that's really what he believed.

Is it possible? Time travel? I've already done it myself. I didn't know how to control my abilities when I first used it, but if she somehow went back in time and killed him, it would explain a lot of things. Not everything though. For one thing, if she killed him, why do I remember him? Why do some of my clones? How does time travel work, exactly? Technically, she might cause a change so drastic that it erases her existence, or mine. Wouldn't that be a paradox?

...What if I've been thinking of time travel incorrectly all this time? There are so many theories regarding it, and I barely know any of them. The one I'm most familiar with is the grandfather paradox. *What would happen if I went back in time and killed my grandfather?*

Perhaps I would cease to exist. Perhaps it would open up a split timeline, or an alternate universe. What if Daisy traveled back in time and killed Silver, creating an alternate universe? That kind of makes sense...

Actually, it doesn't. Now that I think about it, why am I seemingly immune to the effects of the time change? The only way my clones and I don't have our minds changed under that sort of time travel is if we also somehow are ripped out of the timeline we're in, and we get shifted to the other one. But then why does the effect diminish based on the generation of the clone? The further removed they are from me, the less they seem to remember the other timeline. If we were all ripped out of our timeline and placed into another, we should all remember it equally.

Something else is going on, and I don't know what.

"Umi? Are you there?"

I speak out again, but I get no response. If this really is another timeline, does she perhaps not exist anymore? That seems highly unlikely. Something else must be going on. Is she ignoring me? I know her voice is only the slightest bit feminine, but it seems odd an all-powerful sentient AI would be doing something so decidedly female as *giving me the silent treatment*.

Whatever.

I don't know exactly what's going on, but I know it holds important clues for my own future. If I can figure out what's going on, I might be able to figure out what will happen over the rest of my life. Time traveling blindly is not half as smart of an idea as time traveling with knowledge of its mechanics.

I exit the bridge, walking down the hallways until I arrive outside my room. The door opens silently as I walk in. Amelia, of course, is sitting on the bed, reading a book. *The Stepford Wives*. What an odd choice.

"I'm back."

I announce my return with way less enthusiasm than I meant to, but Amelia perks up immediately, setting the book down in a jiffy as she gets off the bed and hugs me. "Welcome back! I missed you!"

Her smile is the exact opposite of my dull expression, and I can tell she has already picked up on my mood. "I had a... hell of a day."

"Oh?" She pulls herself away from me and sits back on the bed, patting the spot beside her as I sit down and wrap my arm back around her shoulder. "What happened?"

Her expression is still relatively happy, but it seems more serious now. "Stonewall was assassinated, the guy who killed him seems to have disappeared from the face of the universe, Stonewall's niece vanished in a way that made me suspect time travel, and now everyone seems to believe she killed her own uncle."

Amelia stared at me expectantly for a moment, but then she realized I had finished explaining. "Oh. That does sound pretty bad. Err..." She glanced away for a moment as she seemed to think about it. "How do you know it was time travel?"

"It seems the most likely route." I explained to her for a few minutes my thoughts on the matter as she nodded and hemmed and hawed while she listened.

"Well, it certainly sounds like it's time travel. But if it is, what does that mean for you? Aren't you trying to prevent a horrible future from happening?"

I stand up from the bed and start walking out of the room as she follows along behind me. "Yeah. It's not easy, either. I don't know what's coming and therefore I can't prepare for it."

Amelia went quiet for a few moments as we entered the dining area. We walked over to the large plexiglass window and stared outside at the Earth below us, feeling once again that weird feeling of awe that we were actually in space.

"Jason, listen, about the talk we had recently. The symptoms are getting worse." Amelia fidgeted slightly. "I talked with Levvy earlier and he told me that he had been able to twitch my finger slightly while I slept. He also is able to take control every time I sleep now. Have you found any solutions?"

I instantly snapped my fingers. "Ah, yes! I almost forgot! It's a good thing you reminded me." I blinked, realizing the solution I had in mind involved wordsmithing. Ah, of course. I don't actually have to wordsmith. My clones can do that for me.

I turned to Amelia and placed my hand on her shoulder. "Before we continue, I need to confirm. It's the energy of small children and those with a lot of life energy left that give you the biggest boost, right?"

Amelia nodded hesitantly. "Err, yeah. Like I said though... I'm not going to hurt anyone, even if you tell me to."

I stifled a chuckle. "If I'm right, that won't be necessary." I quickly sent a mental order to J1-1, the first clone I ever made. He quickly located a hospital with a newborn ward, warping up a child that appeared in my arms. I nearly dropped the little tyke, even though I had anticipated his arrival.

Amelia's eyes bulged as she saw the child in my arms. For a moment, I glimpsed something I would rather not see. "Jason, no. I can't do this. Don't make me hurt him."

I shook my head quickly. "No no, you misunderstand. Tell me if you feel anything."

My clone at the JIB wordsmithed in my place. " **Transfer.** "

A moment later, Amelia's took a step back as she rubbed her chest. "What- what was that? I felt something enter me. Did you just do something?"

The infant who had been moving in my arms fell silent as sleep overtook him. "I did indeed. I transferred his life energy to you, leaving only a small amount behind. He'll be fine. Once he rests up, he'll regenerate it back anyway."

Amelia nodded as she stared at me carefully. "I definitely felt it. I just didn't think you could- well, I mean, I suppose anything is possible when you- err, never mind." I felt my smile fade slightly as Amelia seemed to be hiding something from me. I'd like to try and read her thoughts, but that would be a breach of trust, plus I'd probably have to speak to Leviathan again, and that was something I wasn't looking forwards to.

"Amelia, is something wrong?" I bit my lip slightly as she averted her eyes from mine. She was definitely hiding something from me.

"It's nothing, really. Your powers are just so, uh, incredible. To think they would be capable of solving my dilemma..."

I nodded. So that was it? She was just amazed by my powers. I mean, sometimes I'm amazed too. They seem to have so few limits. "Give me a moment. I'm going to transfer the life energy of every infant in that hospital to you."

In the blink of an eye, the toddler in my arms vanished as my clone quickly sent him back to the hospital whence he came. Amelia staggered back as a wave of energy surged into her.

What happened next was shocking, as her body shrunk ever so slightly. She lost about three inches in height, and seemed to lose two visible years of aging in an instant. Now she looked about twenty or so.

"What...? I feel so dizzy right now." Amelia took a few steps backwards as she grabbed hold of a chair and pulled herself into it. "Jason, h-how much energy did you just give me? This is overwhelming."

I shot the question at my clone and he responded within seconds. "Maybe a couple hundred. I figured humans had so little energy that you'd need a lot to counteract decades of, ah, 'malnutrition'."

Amelia shook her head quickly. "That was a lot, Jason. I guarantee Levvy is sealed up again after that, but that was well over what I used to... absorb... in an entire year. Next time, scale it back a bit. A slow and steady drip is... is... it's much better..." Amelia's eyes blinked slowly as she wobbled in her chair. "I... sleep..."

I took a few quick steps towards her and caught her as she fell forwards, her eyes slamming shut as she lost consciousness. Carefully lifting her in my arms, I walked her over and laid her on the couch, taking a step back to realize what had just happened.

Too much of a good thing can be bad. I'll have to take her advice in the future and transfer energy more slowly, over a longer period of time.

I didn't expect her to de-age, though. That was not within the realm of possibilities I had considered, though it made sense. Based on what she and Leviathan have told me, her energy is constantly fighting his, so she must be aging normally but human energy keeps her locked to her original form from when they bonded together... or whatever.

I feel a flash of guilt as a selfish thought enters my mind. If she de-ages too much, I won't feel comfortable being with her. I can't just give her all the energy she needs, I'll have to somehow maintain a balance.

A balance. Yeah, that's the key. If I'm not comfortable, then she won't be able to be with me anyway. It's for the best that I discuss this with her when she wakes up.

At least this crisis is averted. One good piece of news out of a day of bad. It's something.

"Have a nice day at school, sweetheart." Amy leaned over and kissed her daughter Sarah's head, as she opened up the door hesitantly to step out.

"I don't wanna go to school, mommy." Sarah shuffled her feet slightly as she stared out the opened door beside her into the lightly pattering rain. "The men in the black armor are scary..."

Amy nodded as she glanced at the front gate to London's most prestigious private elementary school. Two huge Enforcers stood, ready to leap into action if anyone should try to harm the school. "I know, baby, but you just don't have to talk to them, alright? They won't bother you if you don't bug them."

Despite the seemingly carefree tone in her mother's voice, Sarah knew instinctively that her mom didn't like the idea of putting her in a private school, as homeschooling had been the preferred route. Still, things changed, and nothing could be done about it.

"All right..." Sarah glumly stepped out of the car, shivering as the raindrops hit her arms. "Bye mommy, have a good day at work!"

Amy nodded reluctantly as she forced a smile on her face, waiting until her daughter slammed the door and was safely inside the gates before releasing it.

Activating the auto-pilot, she set the destination for the London HQ, feeling a bit nervous about the presentation on Revival. Her knowledge as captain of the expedition that had located the planet was somewhat important, since they would want her testimony on its prospects for

tourism, as well as the possibility of it becoming a distant planet for humanity to someday colonize. At 1,500 lightyears away, it was hardly a close system, but if the higher-ups would let go of whatever grudge they had with him, Judicator could make another one of his wormholes, allowing them to travel to this distant star system in the blink of an eye, then he could terraform it too!

The prospect excited her. Being a stay at home mom for eight years wasn't bad at all, but she longed for the days of adventure and discovery.

A whole new planet that might be colonizable raised scientific questions, too, about the existence of other life in the universe. If the Volgrim existed, then perhaps other species and races did as well. Despite how much older and technologically advanced the Volgrim were, there was no evidence from the petabytes of recovered data aboard their captured ships that any other life aside from Earth existed in the galaxy, but that had to be false! The galaxy was massive. If it happened twice, it may have happened a third or fourth time, perhaps in a remote corner where they simply had failed to look.

Even if no other life existed in the galaxy, what of other galaxies? Andromeda was 'nearby' relatively speaking. If Judicator could break the laws of physics and travel 14,000 lightyears in the blink of an eye, why not a million lightyears? Ten million? A hundred million?!

The distances were incredible, to say the least. At warp 10, the fastest speed man could reasonably obtain, it would take a mere month to reach Andromeda. That being said, the energy required would be staggering, it would require a discovery of Trifrancium reserves the size of a planet in order to move a fleet, and to move just a single probe at sustained warp 10 speeds for a month, it would still take a Trifrancium deposit the size of an automobile. Not to mention the effects Warp 10 would put on a biological body... they would certainly die a few hours into the trip.

When put into context, Amy knew the sad truth. Unless Judicator had some incredible secret ability he wasn't disclosing, or the laws of physics themselves were subvertable, humanity was limited just to their own galaxy. If no life existed here, they would never find it elsewhere.

For herself, Amy found that reality painful to accept. Of course, if all other alien races were as hostile as the Volgrim, then perhaps it was a positive thing that they wouldn't exist. Amy shuddered at the thought of something *worse* lying out there, in the far reaches of space.

She reached down and pulled out her makeup as she quickly covered a blemish she had missed from earlier that morning. Best that she look fantastic when presenting before the newly instated Supreme Commander. He was a far less foul man than Stonewall had been, worthy of respect.

Amy shrugged as she glanced at her clock. Still well over an hour before she had to give the presentation. *I suppose I could grab some coffee first. Looking too eager might backfire if I show up forty minutes ahead of schedule.*

Without a hint of reluctance, she changed the autopilot to a nearby coffee shop, ignoring the all too common sight of a man being harassed by the jackboot thugs that Stonewall had put in place.

Perhaps the new commander would be better than the old.

Part 328a: Revelations

April 2nd, 2117

"You're... joking... right?" I felt myself take a step back in horror, my body moving almost of its own accord as my mind was unable to respond coherently.

"He passed away an hour ago. Despite our best efforts, we couldn't save him. He's gone, original."

J3-21 stared at my face with a large blend of sadness and forced lack of emotions, given he knew this would be hard for me to accept.

"How did he... go?" I choked the words up as he stared at me quietly.

"He accidentally electrocuted himself in the bathtub. The good news is that he died instantly, there was very little pain, I'm sure."

"Yeah. That's good news, I suppose. Thanks, Raider." My clone nodded as I mentally switched off the viewscreen.

I slumped back onto my bed as I stared up at my ceiling. A moment later, I smash my fist into the wall out of rage. "FUCK!"

Benjamin Brown was dead. I had thought it was simple, given I had cured him of nano-cancer a few years ago... but then the assassination attempts started, so I gave him a 24/7 security detail of my clones wearing hypersuits all the time. I wouldn't call us good friends anymore, but as Supreme Commander of Earth after Stonewall's death... since that man's toxic attitude towards me was removed, Ben warmed back up and we began to talk more, mending our relations.

One thing was for sure though... he was not the military genius that Stonewall was. We began to loosen the oppressive laws placed upon humanity, only to have demonic terrorism surge a thousand percent in the first year, forcing us to restore martial law.

But through all of that, something began to worry me. It was as if the Grim Reaper himself were after Ben. After I eliminated the nano-cancer, he began to have serious strokes of near-death hitting him, my clones always there to quickly heal him or protect him. The time we put him in a hypersuit for his own safety and it malfunctioned, trying to attack and kill him though... that was the moment I knew something was really up.

I don't want to believe in fate. Yet, it seemed that even after we would save his life, something else would occur that would threaten it again, a few days later.

It was like Ben was destined to die, and I was merely getting in its path.

But of course, when he took a bath and my clones weren't there with him, that was when it would finally happen. Now he was truly dead, well beyond my ability to heal him. My clones had tried, of course, when they found his body... but it was too late. Even my powers had limitations.

Fate... destiny... these are words invented by men who wanted to believe there was something bigger in store for their lives, or perhaps they were dreamed up by others who figured there was no point trying so hard, given you could only work with the cards you were dealt in life.

Myself, I had always waved both away easily. Life is what you make of it, after all...

But now I question that reality. It was beyond bad luck that so many things kept trying to kill him. It was as if the Creator himself wanted Ben dead, and he'd burn no matter what I did to save him.

I turned the viewscreen back on, staring emptily at the news. Seems the demons gained more ground recently, having taken over most of Russia now. They had already taken over Mongolia and were in the process of taking back China.

Who would the humans elect as leader now? Beatrix, maybe? Would they bring her back after her supposed failure a few decades back? Unlikely.

Probably, they would elect some nice-guy who looked pretty and promised to fix their pain. A swap from one ruthless dictator to the next, the difference being that one was obvious, the other subtle. At least I always knew where I stood with Stonewall, even if I didn't like him. With someone who smiles sweetly to my face, it would be difficult to know what they really meant when they said something without reading their mind, which might not be possible these days. After the upper echelons learned that Stonewall had been using Daisy to read their minds, many had begun wearing anti-magic devices to nullify such a possibility.

The more I think about it, the more I have come to realize... there's only one path for humanity. I can't let someone else run it. I won't know if they have humanity's best interests at heart, or their own.

It's time. No more dicking around. The demons are winning, the humans are losing, the angels are barely even players in the war at this point, and I've been busy resting on my laurels, just enjoying my life above the planet where none of it affects me.

No more.

I quickly hop out of bed and glance around the room, setting my eyes on a dresser beside my bed with a false door on its side. Making sure to listen carefully for footsteps, I note that nobody

is walking towards my room. Perfect.

Reaching down, I jimmy the door open, pulling out a small black box.

Before I can take responsibility for Earth, there's something else I have to do. It's time to start taking the initiative, rather than waiting for things to happen.

Sarah stares up at her mother with those adorable puppy-dog eyes that her father couldn't normally resist. "Come on, mom! Everyone is going! Please let me go!"

"Scary holo-films give you nightmares. Besides, it won't finish until half an hour before curfew. That's too dangerous." Amy continued stirring the lemon pudding in the big bowl before her as she chided her daughter.

Sarah groaned loudly as she pivoted around in a full circle on her heel. "Mom! That was a long time ago, I'm not a little kid anymore! I'm not scared of any fake holo-film!"

Amy suppressed her own groan. "Of course you aren't. It's a no from me, young lady. Go get cleaned up, your father will be home soon."

Sarah threw her hands up in the air as she pouted and sulked her way to the bathroom. "You never let me do anything!"

Amy just tucked a smile inside of herself as she heard the bathroom door slam shut. A moment later, it creaked open as her daughter's voice spoke out guiltily. "Sorry... didn't mean to slam it."

"That's all right, sweetheart." Amy giggled as the door closed again, but quietly this time.

As the shower turned on, Amy stuck the pudding in the fridge, glancing over at the soup that was just about ready. Vegetable beef, with some steak diced and thrown in for good measure. Jorge would love it.

She glanced down at her watch, tapping it uneasily. It was only ten minutes to 7, and he needed to be back before curfew was in effect. Still, he had government ID, so it was unlikely they would detain him, let alone stick him inside of a facility.

Perhaps.

Amy's smile had darkened now, as she kept glancing out the window, waiting for his hover-jeep to pull in. The sound of the shower squeaking as Sarah turned it off was heard behind her, as Amy quickly glanced at her watch. Seven minutes past seven now. Where was Jorge?

A minute or so later, Sarah stepped out of the shower, perking up as she saw her mother standing at the window. "Where's dad?"

"He's not home yet." Amy tried to force a weak smile, but it didn't come. This was very unlike him to be late.

Sarah shrugged. "Dad can take care of himself. He has a gun, you know!"

"A gun won't do any good against government thugs, sweetheart." Amy bit her lip as she saw Sarah walking away in the window's reflection. Sarah didn't seem worried. Maybe a child's intuition should be trusted. Though, to be fair, she wasn't even thirteen yet, so she didn't know much about the world.

Just as Amy started to glance down at her watch again, a familiar set of lights pulled into the driveway as she breathed a deep sigh of relief.

Jorge stepped out, pausing for a minute to look around before he opened up the back door, hauling out a massive heavy looking box. Amy quickly opened the door and walked out to him. "Did you get stopped?"

He shook his head as he dropped the box onto the ground. It made a dull thud as it struck the pavement. "No. I just, err, had something to pick up."

Amy flicked a curious glance at the box he was holding. "What's that?" She crossed her arms and struck a haughty pose. "Did you get me a present?"

Jorge grinned sheepishly. "Actually, yeah. I know our anniversary is coming up soon, and since we've technically been married, like, 50 years..."

Amy's expression melted as she stared at him. "You're serious? Wow, that's so sweet! What did you get me? I didn't think you'd remember!"

He grinned again as he leaned forwards and gave her a quick kiss. "You'll find out soon. Help me get this inside, we don't wanna be outside after curfew anyway."

Amy nodded quickly as she grabbed the other end, lifting up as he did. "This thing weighs a ton. Is this a full set of body armor or something?"

"Come on, it's a surprise. Don't keep trying to ruin it, honey." Jorge's grin exploded as he saw the curiosity becoming burned onto her face. Amy loved surprises, and was also famously impatient. "Oh, but before we open this, we have to eat first."

Her curiosity turned into annoyance in an instant. "Damn you. Alright, fine, you win this round."

"Indeed. We've got another box after this one, so let's get this done, quick."

* * *

About an hour later, everyone rubbed their bellies as they glanced back and forth at each other with a smile. Even Sarah's tantrum from earlier was gone, as she and her mom had been eyeballing the box madly from the beginning of the meal.

"Okay, can we open it now, dad? Pleeeeeease?" Sarah hopped in her seat as she shot another look at it.

Jorge fought madly to maintain his frame. "Nope, you have to help mom clean the dishes first, then we can open it." He sucked down the laughter he had been holding in all evening.

Both women at the table glanced at each other before looking back to him. "The dishes can wait. I want to know what's inside too!" Amy quickly stood up and strode over to the box, finally having reached her breaking point. "Come on, Sarah, help me open this."

Jorge quickly walked over to them, holding out a small pocket knife. "Okay, okay. But be very careful, it's extremely expensive. I had to pull some strings to get it."

Amy cocked an eyebrow at that statement, but said nothing in response. Slicing carefully through the tape that held the edges together, Amy cleanly lifted the top of the box open, noting it was filled to the brim with packing peanuts. "What kind of expensive item ships in an old classic-style cardboard box with these little peanuts in it?"

"One procured through backdoor means. It's legal, but very very hard to get hold of, even for someone in the government." Jorge said nothing else as he let his wife quickly scoop the peanuts out, setting them in a pile on the floor. Those would be a real mess to clean up, but luckily none of the three of them would have to do that later.

She gasped in amazement as her hand hit something with a very odd texture. "Is this... hair?"

"Maaaaaybe..." Jorge tilted his voice slightly as he sent her an innocent smile.

Amy dug more peanuts out as she and Sarah both gaped at the box's contents. "This is... a robot?"

"Android, actually." Jorge smiled smugly as she stared at it incredulously.

"Baby, this is great but... this must have cost a fortune... how could we possibly afford this? They aren't even out for consumers yet."

Jorge nodded knowingly. "I managed to get signed up for beta-testing. Meet the new member of our house... Jerry. I named him that because it's easy to remember, but he's actually part of the upcoming OMEN series."

Sarah watched as her mother pulled the box apart, revealing a strangely androgynous face with realistic looking skin and no visible metal parts. "Dad, what does 'OMEN' mean?"

"I can't remember, something about mechanical neohumans or something. These are going to be used for sending out unmanned probes to distant planets, that way the ships can travel faster than Warp 9 safely. The Exploration Committee will be targeting planets that have a high likelihood of being habitable to cut down on Trifrancium waste."

Amy nodded in amazement. "This is crazy. Aren't there only like a few dozen of these in existence? What are we even going to do with this thing?"

"Oh, that's easy. Part of the beta testing process is that they want to make these mass-producible in order to function properly as members of a household. We'll be having Jerry clean the house up, do the dishes, and maybe even cook some simple meals. Also, from what I've heard, he makes for excellent security, being very hard to damage."

Amy glanced at her husband knowingly. "Oh, I see what you're getting at. You mean we can finally leave Sarah at home alone and Jerry will protect her?"

"Right. We'll be able to take that vacation to Mars I've been promising." Jorge glanced down at his daughter and then back to his wife as a crooked smile spread across his face. "You know, just the two of us."

Sarah rolled her eyes. "I didn't wanna go anyway, it's just some crappy dustbowl."

"Watch your mouth." Amy glared at her daughter, the sexy mood having been killed. Being a parent could be such a drag sometimes. "Anyway, let's flip his switch! I wanna see what he's like!"

Jorge quickly reached back and tweaked a button on the back of the android's head, turning on the central power converter as the robot took a few seconds to grind to life.

"Greeting: Hello, humans. My designation is OMEN M.K. I, Model 16. What are your names?"

I sauntered out into the dining area, where Amelia was sitting all by herself at a table, flipping through yet another book. She seemed to be quite the avid reader, having consumed over a hundred books a year. This time she appeared to be reading *The Wizard of Oz*, another classic novel.

She instantly heard me walk in the room, even though I had been walking rather quietly. "Oh, you're awake!"

I was at her side within a few more seconds, my long stride clearing the distance in no time at all. "Yeah. Listen... do you remember my friend, Ben Brown?"

Her smile faded away as she detected something was off in my voice tone. "Is he okay?"

"No. He died today. This time, we couldn't bring him back." I felt myself suck in air quickly as a sharp pang of emotion overcame me. "He accidentally electrocuted himself in the bathtub. We didn't find out until a half hour after the fact, so we couldn't bring him back this time."

Amelia's smile was gone now as she stared at me sullenly. "I'm sorry, Jason. I know he was a good friend of yours. You kept your clones with him for a reason, after all."

"I couldn't save him. It... it was like the universe itself wanted him gone."

"Don't beat yourself up. You did the very best you could." Amelia pulled me down to her level as she embraced me, patting my back comfortingly. "I'm sure he knew you were the best friend anyone could have. He didn't die with regrets, Jason."

I wrapped my arms around her and pulled her in close as I fought away tears. It wasn't a manly thing to cry, but I had lost so many friends over my lifetime. Everyone I grew close to would inevitably die.

They would all die... but... I couldn't keep losing people. There had to be another way.

I pulled away from Amelia quickly as I wiped at my eyes. "Listen, Amelia, I wanted to talk to you. Not about Ben, though. I've been... thinking. I've been doing a lot of pondering lately, but his death sealed the deal."

She nodded as she put a hand on my shoulder. "What's on your mind?"

"I've been trying to fight an uncertain future filled with doom, but throughout that, I've also been trying to remember what I'm fighting for. Everyone I know and grow to care for eventually dies. I keep getting left behind."

Amelia shook her head quickly. "That's not true, Jason. Don't think like that. I'm here with you, and so is Helen."

"I know, Amelia. I know that very well. That's why I wanted to talk to you." I felt myself glance away awkwardly before returning back to gaze into her dark brown eyes. "I'm not good with stuff like this, but I need to say it. We've been 'more than friends' for a long time now, for nearly half a decade. We've known each other for way longer than that too. We would never do anything to hurt each other now."

A hint of recognition appeared in her eyes as she looked at me softly. "Jason... what are you trying to say?"

"I'm not good with words, believe it or not. But... I know that after all we've been through and how much we depend on each other that I... I love you, Amelia. Very much. I don't want to lose you."

Her breathing caught in her throat as she pulled back from me slightly, shock in her eyes. "You've... never said that before. Never. You really do? You love me?"

I nodded quickly as I reached behind me and telekinetically yanked the box from the other side of the room into my hand. I had placed it in such a way that she wouldn't see it, and with her eyes transfixed on mine, she didn't even see it flying through the air.

"I do, Amelia. I used to have reservations, but no more. I fully trust you." I glanced down at her neck, reaching with my free hand to caress the cross that I had given to her as a gift many Christmases ago. "You still wear this."

She reached up and touched my hand lightly, pressing it against her neck. "Yes. I never take it off."

"That's good. It's been a long time since I gave you a present." I quickly brought around the box from behind myself as I cracked it open in front of her, revealing a ring I had crafted myself with wordsmithing, one pure white diamond shimmering in the middle.

Amelia froze as she stared at it. "Jason. Is this... is this...?"

I smiled fiercely at her as I spoke the words quietly, dropping down to one knee before her. "Amelia, I love you. I don't want to lose you. I want us to be together until death do us part. Will you marry me?"

Her face remained stoic as she stared at the ring, a silence hanging between us for two very long seconds. I could almost hear both of our hearts pounding as she couldn't seem to tear her eyes away from it.

Finally, she spoke. "Yes! Of course! I love you too! I can't believe it took us this long... t-to..." The smile that had spread across her face wavered for a moment as tears began to form in the corners of her eyes. "I'm crying... I thought... tears only came when I was sad..." She wiped her eyes quickly as she smiled even harder at me. "Jason! I love you too! I can't believe I'm really saying it!"

She leaned forwards quickly, her face meeting mine, as we shared a long passionate kiss. This wasn't like the ones we had shared over the last few years in each others' arms, this was something different. It had a tingly feeling and an exciting new meaning to it.

For several seconds, we expressed our emotions in the most primal way two people could. It was passionate, and thrilling at the same time!

Finally, we peeled apart as I blinked somberly. "Here. Let me put it on your hand." I fumbled clumsily with it for a moment as she giggled excitedly, but it was on in the blink of an eye, and she marveled at it.

"It's so beautiful."

"I made it myself, just for you." I felt my smile fade slightly as something new came to mind. "Listen, Amelia. I've never lied to you, but I haven't fully told you the truth about myself. I haven't told you about my powers, or how they work. It's not fair, now that I know your secret. I won't hide anything from you anymore. It's time I told you how it all works."

Amelia's grin widened at my words. "Really?! You'll finally tell me?! But... Jason, I already know. I've known for years, you silly man."

I jerked my head back in surprise. "You did? Why didn't you say anything?"

"I was... just waiting for you to tell me yourself. I didn't want to put you on the spot. I just... I didn't think we would ever be in a situation like this."

I swallowed heavily as I took in her almost regal beauty, her elegant figure sitting on a simple wooden dining table chair, and how incredibly beautiful she was. Wearing a long white dress, her flowing black hair stood out dramatically against the white backdrop, giving her the figure of... a princess, almost.

"I didn't either. Time changes people, Amelia. From now on, no more secrets. I'm going to tell you everything. We need to be best friends, partners, and lovers. You need to know exactly what I'm fighting to protect."

Amelia licked her lips as she threw herself on me, catching me by surprise as we landed on the floor and she straddled me sexily. "We can talk about that boring stuff later. I'm in a really good mood right now."

I grinned madly at her. "Me too. Your room or mine?"

"I say we just create a new one for the both of us."

"I like the way you think. For now, we'll go to mine though. We can save *that* boring stuff for later."

Amelia rolled her eyes and laughed. "Oh, you!"

Part 329a:

I stared forwards at the mirror as Amelia reached way up to adjust my tie. "I'm surprised you know anything about this."

Amelia shrugged and smiled. "I'm still a woman, Jason. I know a thing or two about fashion, and I've known many men over my lifetime, even if I held no real affection for them. Adjusting a tie is nothing."

"Yeah, I guess not." She took a step away as I patted down the professional looking black suit. Truth be told, I wasn't much for wearing anything that wasn't casual or meant for battle, but she seemed to think this would make a bigger impact.

Amelia swayed on her heels for a moment as she appeared to be admiring me. "You cut quite a dashing figure, you know. You should wear a suit more often."

"Err, if you want me to, I guess." I scratched my chin, noting some unshaven stubble I'd have to get rid of. "This is pretty big. I have no idea how it's going to change the future, honestly, or if it will have any effect at all."

Amelia rolled her eyes, but kept a smile visible. "There you go worrying about the future again."

"I can't help it, Amelia. A future where everyone is ruled over by demons, humans are slaves, and angels are extinct does not sound up my alley. I don't want it to happen under my watch." I paused, searching for words, but Amelia filled the void.

"You've already changed the future though. The Volgrim are basically gone, and we're on our way to taking back control of the Earth in order to eradicate demon-kind."

"I'm not so sure. There are still two predictions that have yet to be completely nullified. I've told you one of them, but the other..." I glanced over at her, feeling my smile evaporate. "You'll probably think this is the best news ever, but in the future I come from, you killed Satan."

Amelia blinks at me in surprise as her smile turns into a look of awe. "Really? I killed him?"

"You're so predictable." I chuckled slightly, but felt my gut clench up. "Yeah, you not only killed him, you apparently made him your puppet."

"When? Is there a deadline? How did I do it? Did I massacre him?" Amelia smashes me in the face with a barrage of questions, but I wave my hand at her to silence her.

"I don't know the details. What I do believe though is that it must be impossible, as of now. You simply are, no offense, too weak to take him on. It must be in the future or something, or

rather it would have been, if you had gotten stronger."

Amelia meets my eyes for a moment before slowly turning away to stare blankly at the wall to my side as she taps her lip. "What you really mean is that I would have been able to beat him if I'd kept consuming, isn't it?"

I rubbed my back slowly. "That's the gist of it. So, uh, don't go nomming people... okay?"

Amelia immediately cocked an eyebrow at my weird phrasing. " *Nomming*? Come on, Jason, it's hardly even worth making a lame joke like that. No more."

"Sorry, sorry. Anyway, let's get a move on. Can't keep the world waiting." I reached over and put my hand down on Amelia's shoulder, smiling as I realized I was about to wordsmith right in front of her for the first time ever.

Heh, you know, if she understands how my powers work now, then she won't be able to be surprised by them if we were to meet in the future. I don't know why I never thought of that before. I guess that really means I did change the flow of time.

"Teleport. "

Jorge plopped down on the couch as the view-screen started playing yet another one of those damned public service announcements. Something about an important world leader announcing his resignation or whatever. Jorge wasn't one to really care about the news, but this was going to be played across all channels, so he might as well watch it.

Sarah walked downstairs in a hurry, followed by Jerry who was trying to keep up. Given she was twelve years old and full of energy, it was no surprise that the clunky android was having some difficulty following her frenetic pace.

"Dad, look! I braided his hair! Now he's pretty!" Sarah hopped excitedly as she pointed at Jerry's head.

Jorge stared over at the skin-covered automaton blankly for a moment. "You... braided Jerry's hair? Why?"

"It's funny, that's why! Next I'm going to put lots of colored beads in his hair, then he'll look fabulous!"

Jorge stifled a snicker. "Jerry, how do you feel about this?"

"Response: I am incapable of any particular emotional response to this stimulus. Query: Is there an appropriate reaction I should employ for when Sarah braids my patented Dharma Co. Nu-hair?"

Jorge shrugged. "I don't think so. I was just commenting on the, err, absurdity of a robot's hair being braided."

"Correction: I am an android, not a robot."

"Yeah, whatever." Jorge rolled his eyes. Jerry was always picky about what he was being called.

The sound of a dish clanking in the kitchen sink made Jorge remember what his wife was up to. "Amy, go ahead and have Jerry take over. He can finish cleaning up dinner, you should come in here and watch the announcement." He spoke loudly enough for her to hear him, and she responded in kind.

"All right, I'm coming, I'm coming!" Amy mumbled something to herself that Jorge didn't catch, then emerged from the kitchen a few moments later, drying her hands on a towel. "They're all yours, Jerry."

The android adjusted his facial transistors to make a plastic-looking smile appear. "Affirmation: No problem, Amy! This is what I was designed to do!"

Jerry strode into the kitchen with purpose as Amy sat down in Jorge's lap, giving him a tender kiss as their daughter looked away in mock disgust. "Adults are so gross sometimes!"

Jorge chortled. "Someday, you'll have a nice man and you'll know what this feels like too, honey. Of course, you have to wait until you're older first. If you bring a boy home in the next couple of years, I'll kick his butt."

"Boys are gross too! No thank you!" Sarah turned and bounced up the stairs back to her room as the program came on that the adults were waiting for.

The mayor of London stood on stage, hemming and hawing for a moment as assistants rushed up to hand him some hard-copy papers, a rare sight to see nowadays, before he turned to face the camera. "My fellow Britannians, I am the mayor of the city of London, the capital of our beloved empire, and my name is Simon Barron. Unfortunately, before our guest speaker can be here, I have terrible news to relay to the people of our empire. At four o'clock, two days ago, our Supreme Commander, Benjamin Garrison Brown, died peacefully in his sleep. He had been quietly suffering from a resurgence of the nano-cancer that plagued him a few years ago, and was unable to fight it off any longer. Let us all have a moment of silence for our beloved Third Supreme Commander."

As the crowd went silent for a moment, Jorge shot a look of surprise at Amy. "Weren't you over at the central HQ yesterday? Did you hear anything about this?"

She shook her head. "No, not a peep. They must have been keeping this hush hush."

The mayor, Simon, coughed twice before continuing to speak. "Benjamin Brown was only our Supreme Commander for but five years, however he left an indelible mark on our hearts in the decades prior, thanks to the glorious extermination of the Volgrim menace directly at his hands, as well as the dozens of times he led our forces under the command of the first Supreme Commander, Beatrix, during those hellish early days."

Simon paused for a minute as he shuffled his notes around. "In any case, with Benjamin Brown gone, and no obvious candidates left to replace him, we now will take a moment to listen to some words from one of the most important beings in the cause of fighting for our race's survival. Over a hundred years ago, this man spoke out in front of the entire world to warn us, with his knowledge of the future, about a horrifying alien menace! We all know him as Judicator, but today he is coming to us a new man, one we will finally see unmasked for the first time ever."

"My fellow countrymen and women, I give you Jason L. Hiro... Judicator!" Simon waved his hand dramatically behind himself to a small group of sharply dressed dignitaries, as an especially tall mountain of a man strode forwards. With his golden hair combed beautifully, and just the right amount of gel added to make it glisten under the early summer sun, he looked incredibly handsome.

So handsome in fact, that Amy found herself leaning towards the viewscreen slightly to get a better look.

"I'm right here, honey. I still exist." Jorge reached his hand around in front of her face, causing her to blink quickly. "You're still on my lap you know."

Amy blushed as she quickly stood up. She felt herself swooning slightly at the sight of the ridiculously hunky looking man on screen. "It's nothing personal, sweetheart, I just can't help but admire a sharp dressed man who knows how to flaunt it."

The man, Jason, walked up to the podium, clearly being somewhat uncomfortable with crowds, but carefully maintaining his composure. For a moment, he seemed to whisper something to himself, almost like a single word.

Out of nowhere, his entire body became relaxed in the blink of an eye, as he began to talk.

I stared out at the crowd nervously as I approached the podium, but I wordsmithed ' **calm** ' to get my nerves under control. It worked so effectively that I immediately felt completely nonchalant about speaking to five billion live viewers at once.

"My fellow Britanniens, I am Judicator. For the first time ever, I am revealing my face to the world. I have decided that Humanity has passed what I call the 'imminent danger' threshold. The Volgrim are dead, so we are in no danger of them destroying our home-world. However, the

demons are making big gains, and despite Stonewall and Benjamin Brown's methods of instating martial law to keep terrorism at bay, I believe citizens should enjoy a more free, open society, while also not having to worry about the possibility of becoming a victim to a deranged demonic attack."

"As such, I am lifting the curfew and the other oppressive rules that are in place throughout all of our major cities. Some places will be exempt from this freedom, due to their locations and critical importance to the overall war effort, but as the war progresses and we make big gains against the demonic threat, we will scale them back as well. To maintain law and order, we will continue to use Enforcers, but we will be focusing mainly on... surveillance."

I swallowed, thinking to myself that what I really meant was having my clones monitor Earth 24/7. I should probably start monitoring the labyrinth, as well.

"Next, I need to discuss the angels. The angels will be contributing more actively in the fight to exterminate the demons. Angels are the penultimate force for righteousness, while demons are the epitome of evil. Eradicating the demons and allying with the angels is only sensible. I will be taking the lead as the new Supreme Commander personally, putting an end to the practice of elections as we know them. Under my leadership, we will be abandoning various policies put in place by Stonewall, and the neo-distrust of angels is one of them."

The crowd around me was especially stirred by that message. I glanced over towards a large group of people wearing white, noting they seemed to be members of the cult-like church I had heard so much about in recent years. Their membership was swelling to nearly five million, and rapidly increasing on a yearly basis. I'd have to talk to Zeus or Gabriel about them to find out what that meant for the angels.

I droned on and on for a while, discussing various actions I'd be taking over the next few years, as the crowd nodded along, sometimes cheering, but even booing on a few occasions, such as when I discussed ignoring the western USA for now, given how much time and effort it would take to retake it compared to the nearer parts of the world.

I personally think that most ordinary people can't conceive of the time it would require to take back places that had become firmly entrenched demon territory. Still, the enthusiasm for winning the war was half the enthusiasm people had for finally being free of oppressive laws set in place by Stonewall. I could ride off that goodwill for a long while.

"In conclusion, we have a long road ahead of us. If we are to return to pre-curfew levels of society, we need to be more mindful of our surroundings. If you spot suspicious activity, you must report it to law enforcement at once. If the demons begin increasing the levels of terrorism that we saw when curfew was temporarily alleviated, we'll have to bring it back. I don't want

that, none of you want that, so let us all do our best to keep each other safe. I'm Jason Leonardo Hiro, the fourth Supreme Commander, and I am at your service."

The crowd cheered and applauded as I waved to them silently. Unlike the last time I had spoken to the world, people seemed to be much more receptive, possibly because of the fact I wasn't introducing myself by neutralizing several guards and putting the leaders of the world in perceived danger. Also likely due to the fact I wasn't wearing a faceless mask.

I walked away from the stage, still feeling unnaturally calm from the wordsmithing I had cast upon myself earlier. It was sort of crazy that I could simply adjust my emotions like that.

I walked out the backside of the stage as I heard the mayor beginning to speak behind me, as he hushed the crowd down. "That was a public introduction to the former recluse known as Judicator, now the fourth Supreme Commander of Earth! We can all only hope..."

I ignored the rest of the introduction speech. None of it was important and would only be used as soundbites for the news later that day. "**Transfer.**"

I felt my body pop in at the surveillance office inside the JIB, where all my clones quickly blinked and looked at me as I arrived. A familiar face appeared, as J1-1, the first clone I ever made, walked over to me. "We just saw the announcement. Wish you had told us about it first..."

I shrugged. "I figured time was of the essence. If we just told everyone Benjamin was dead, there would possibly be chaos. Best to control the message quickly."

J1-1 stared at me for a moment as he pursed his lips. "Mmm. Well, the thing is, I wanted to talk to you about something important. Come with me." He beckoned towards the doorway that led out of Surveillance.

We walked at a fairly brisk pace, and I couldn't help noticing that he seemed slightly on edge. "What's this about? You're not usually one to be so tight lipped."

"I haven't told anyone else yet, or you. I wasn't even sure if it was the right thing to do, or how you'd react. We both think so differently these days." He spoke vaguely and nibbled on his lip, as if he was really afraid of my reaction to... whatever he was going to show me. I decided to just wait and see what the issue was.

Finally, we arrived at the doorway to his bedroom, a fairly large space with lots of floor area to make it as homey as he wanted. We entered and I immediately noticed that it was quite barren. He only had a dresser off to the side, a large mirror for checking his appearance, and the wall-mounted replicator for creating meals.

"Your room is pretty empty."

He shrugged, as turned to look at me, anxiousness apparent on his face. "Yeah, uh, I don't stay in here much. Always busy. Anyway, here goes nothing." He put his hand on my shoulder. "**Transfer.**"

Instantly he and I vanished and reappeared in a very dark room, the only visible light coming from a host of strange objects some distance away.

"Damn, the power failed again. Good thing I checked actually." J1-1 grunted as he walked forwards towards the source of the light. I followed along, taking in a sharp breath as I realized what the light's source was.

"Hey, are these... cryopods?" I stared down at a tube-like device, big enough for a man to fit inside, with a large glass cover that was frosted over, preventing me from seeing inside it.

"Sort of. Like I said, I didn't ask you if it was okay to do this, and I made a judgement call. This is, the, err... 'Backup Room'. I've been working on this for about a year now. I consider it a fail-safe reset button."

I eyeballed him carefully. "What's going on here, exactly? Who's in these pods?"

"World leaders. Dignitaries. Basically the most important humans on Earth, ones critical to the war effort." J1-1 sheepishly grinned. "I hope you aren't too mad."

"No, I'm not mad. Actually it's smart. But... wait, if you brought me here, then...!"

"Yeah, Benjamin Brown is here. He's in this pod." J1-1 beckoned towards a pod he was standing beside. "I had planned to tell you about this place, then we could thaw Ben out, make up some story about him hitting his head, and none would be the wiser. You and us clones were the only ones who knew he had died, anyway."

I slowly reached up and rubbed my eyes. "Damn. You should have told me sooner. What took you so long?"

J1-1 shuffled his feet slightly. "I... overslept. Kind of forgot, to be honest. Then I heard about the announcement and just about shit myself."

"Yeah, you're my clone alright." I stared at the pod beside him, feeling a weird hesitation in my mind. "I don't know what to do. I already told the world he was dead. If he reappears, alive, it's going to look damn suspicious." I suddenly felt myself flinch as a thought entered my mind. "Oh my god, what if... what if when he died, he became an angel?"

J1-1 shook his head quickly. "Not possible. He was a devout atheist and somewhat opposed the angels anyway. Only the believers get revived when they die. That's how the magical contract works."

I nodded vacantly. "Yeah. I guess that makes sense." A sense of dread crept up my spine as I looked the pod up and down. "So... do we kill him, then? He can't just be thawed out and retake his place in society now. Even if he could, this is a clone, not the original."

J1-1 looked me in the eye, a sense of unease filling his vision. "I don't know what to do either. I agree that the clone is his own being and not merely a copy of the original, plus this 'backup' of Ben's is over 6 months old. He would be missing a lot of critical information that happened recently. I wasn't sure if reintegration would work or not anyway."

I bit my lip as I pressed my hand against the cold glass. "So we should kill him."

It wasn't a question, but a statement. I didn't want to do it, as seeing my friend die a second time would wound me deeply... but I couldn't see a way to make this work.

"Let's hold off. Murder isn't right, and he's not going anywhere important. Might as well just leave him here and maybe we'll figure out some way we could reintegrate him into society."

I blinked slowly. It seemed my clone wasn't any more eager to do the deed than I was. "Fine. We'll just wait, then. Who else do you have here? Not Stonewall, obviously?"

"No, not him. He died long before I started making backups. All of the current prime ministers are in here, the presidents of a few European countries, and plenty of empty pods are left over for more as needed."

I scratched my chin as I pondered what to do. "Don't make any more of these clones. Morally, I'm not sure what to do with them if we fail to reintegrate them smoothly, and once they've been here too long, it might be impossible, meaning we have to get rid of them. I don't like either thought. Let the dead rest."

J1-1 lowered his gaze sullenly. "Alright, you're the boss. I knew it was going to be a futile endeavor, but I'm just glad you didn't do anything crazy when you found out."

"That's not me anymore. I'm trying to be a more balanced man." I shrugged at him as I wordsmithed again. " **Return.** "

Amelia sulked as she sat behind the stage where Jason had given his big announcement to the world. Waving her legs back and forth in between the legs of her chair, she groaned loudly as she glanced over at a digital clock on the wall. Already, the sound of people packing up the stage could be heard, as they shuffled around, picking up this item and that one.

"He forgot about me." Amelia mumbled to herself as she mentally counted how long it had been since he teleported away. "Jerk. Meanie."

Leviathan bubbled up from within her. "Princess, you seem to be saddened. Did something happen?"

"Yeah. Jason ditched me after his speech. He forgot he even brought me with him. He'll probably remember later and pop back down to pick me up, but still..." Amelia stood up and started walking out past the curtain, watching as the last few thousand audience members at the massive outside stadium were slowly moving towards the exits in the distance.

"It is disappointing that he would simply leave you behind. Considering his proposal for marriage, it is actually unthinkable, from my perspective." Leviathan chided her gently, but she ignored him.

"Jason is a nice guy. You should stop being so suspicious of him. He has lots of plans that will improve everyone's lives, and because of him, I don't have to eat people anymore. That's good!"

Leviathan grunted neutrally, trying not to betray any of his opinions on the matter. "Hmm. Yes, good. Still, you were steadily gaining power as time went on, and once you were even able to best the most powerful of heroes with little effort. Can you honestly say you don't miss the thrill of battle?"

Amelia shrugged. "I mean, fighting is fun, especially when I win, but playing card games and board games is fun too. I might even try playing those holographic games too. I don't have to kill things to have fun, you know."

Leviathan grumbled silently to himself for a few moments. "Princess, isn't it still possible that Jason is merely using you?"

Amelia hopped down off the stage, taking off her shoes to walk barefoot in the stadium's grass. "Levy, you're really ridiculous sometimes. You never stop treating him like an enemy, do you? It's like you can't trust my judgement. I'm not a child anymore, and I'm not just saying that because of the way I look now. I'm thousands of years old, practically a deity compared to most humans nowadays."

Leviathan chuckled. "And I am tens of millions of years old, perhaps older. I remember being formed by the creator himself. Or... perhaps it was the archangels. Perhaps those who came before the titans. It's been so long."

"Yeah, okay? I get it. You're way older than me. Sheesh, I'm just making a point." Amelia rolled her eyes as she flopped backwards on the cool grass. "It can be really annoying sometimes, having an immortal dragon inside myself who questions my every decision. Sometimes I wonder if you're worried about me, or yourself."

Leviathan stayed silent for a moment. He felt an odd sensation inside himself, one he had never experienced in his life. If he were a more self-aware being, he might even consider it... guilt. "I... I never meant to give such an impression. I thought.... you might be..." For once,

words of wisdom didn't come, as he felt himself second guessing his recent thoughts and actions.

"You thought what? That I didn't notice what you've been getting at? Levvy, I know you're selfish, okay? That doesn't bother me. You are who you are. What bothers me is how you keep lying to me about your true intentions. You may be a wise old dragon, but I am a woman, and I have a woman's intuition. If you have something you want to say, just say it! Don't attack Jason, he's not the cause for the feelings that you have right now. He's more like a symptom. Anyway, whether you like him or don't, I care for him. He was a jerk today, and he forgot all about me, but this was the first time ever. I'll forgive him, just like I'm forgiving you now, understand?"

Amelia sighed as she blew on a wispy strand of hair that fell over one of her eyes. "I'm a good girl now, so why don't you try being a good boy, for once?"

Leviathan stayed silent, as he pondered her words.

Part 330a:

"CAN I GET AN AAAAAMEN UP IN HERE?" Clarence screamed into the microphone as he dropped to his knees and threw his hands up into the sky dramatically.

"AMEN!" The massive auditorium full of people cheered in delight as they whipped their heads up and down furiously.

"God is watching! God loves us all! God is just!" Preacher Clarence roared with all his might, ad-libbing as he always did. "God has seen the evil in this world, and struck down both of the Supreme Commanders who defied his will! Fake leaders, false prophets, agents of the anti-Christ! He has seen and He has not liked what he has seen! If ye stand against the lord, ye will be struck down with DIVIIINE power!" Clarence felt his eyes bulge as he bellowed the words out at the top of his lungs.

Several women at the front were shrieking and wailing about how much they loved him, but Clarence ignored them, for he'd have plenty of their company later that night. Such was the life of a humble mega-star pastor.

"I have spoken to the angels again, and they assure me with all of their heart that the end is coming! The wicked will be struck DOWN! The unfaithful left to die in the streets where they belong! Those who fight on behalf of Satan the Devil will fail, for God is just, and God has the sword of righteousness! Believe! Believe!" Clarence halted for a split second, unsure if he had felt a vein popping in his head. Best to just ignore it. High blood pressure was normal when one lied as much as he tended to.

"When a brother strikes you, turn the other cheek! Like Jesus Christ himself said, the power of forgiveness knows no limits! The Devil cannot enter our hearts if we accept the love of Christ inside ourselves! Bow with me, bow down to the sky, for the angels know that we believe! Come now, my children, bow! Bow!" Clarence hurled himself to the ground dramatically, his chest heaving as he pulled the mic away, sensing that the entire crowd was bowing, even as they failed to contain their excitement. Just a few seconds to catch his breath... that's all he needed.

Who said being a humble preacher was easy? It took a lot of energy to keep the flock of idiot sheep excited enough to come twice a week. Especially if he expected them to open their pockets up!

He staggered back to his feet, hiding his absolute exhaustion with a smile full of bravado. "I thank all of you for coming! We have broken five million faithful members just this week! Imagine the smile on the face of God as He looks down and sees the people remembering him!

For a long time, we struggled to find ourselves in darkness... but... hah... now we can see as clear as day!" Clarence caught himself almost running out of breath mid-sentence. *Damn, need to cut this twenty minutes short.*

He closed his eyes and clasped his hands together silently as he bowed his head. "Now for a moment of silence in thanks to our lord, Jesus Christ."

The crowd also quickly clasped their hands in unison, as the whole stadium went eerily silent for a few moments. Clarence swallowed carefully, feeling like if he tried too hard to breathe, everyone would hear just how out of shape he really was. After a few seconds, he raised his head back up. "Thank you all for coming. Make sure to drop a dollar in the plate if you love Jesus!" He smiled, knowing many of the more 'pious' members of the church always tried to compete with each other over how much they donated. For them, the more they donated, the more status it made them feel like they had in Heaven.

Idiots.

Clarence turned away and walked off stage, smiling and waving at the people along the sides, as the people behind him roared in applause.

* * *

Finally, he was back in his dressing room. He glanced down and saw his hands were shaking. "Son of a bitch. These anxiety attacks are gonna be the death of me." He reached in the drawer beside his changing table and pulled out a tube of red pills, erratically dumping three into his hand. *Doc said to only take one, but I need to calm these jitters down.*

After a few minutes, he took three slow, deep breaths, as he felt his center returning. "I don't know how much more of this I can take."

"For your sake, I hope you've got more left." A sudden voice from behind him made Clarence's aura vanish as he shrieked and fell off his chair. Glancing back, he saw that same Archangel standing over in the doorway, appearing silently as he always did.

"Raphael?! Why must you scare me like that?!" Clarence jumped to his feet, noticing his dark skin was covered in flecks of white powder that had fallen off the desk when he did. He quickly wiped at his face and glared at the man on the other side of the room. "Alright, what do you want? You're never here for good news."

Raphael shrugged as he tottered on his cane over towards a bench on the other side of the room, setting himself into it with a grunt of pleasure. "Perhaps I'm just here to say hello. Why must you always assume the worst when you see me?"

Clarence stifled the urge to roll his eyes. "I've been thinking this for a long time, but I'm just not quite sure who the bad guys really are; the demons, or the angels? I haven't spoken with a demon before, but you angels are quite selfish from what I've seen. You almost make me not feel guilty about how badly I'm fleecing these people."

"Sounds like your way of saying you feel guilty anyway." Raphael chuckled as he pointed a finger at Clarence. "As I've always said, you can have all the money, liquor, and women you want. I only ask that it not interfere with your preaching, and that you continue to get people to worship us. You've done very well for yourself, you know. Not only have our angels actually increased in number, they've gained power as well. Soon, we'll be able to take the fight to the demons."

Clarence sat back in his chair and reached for a cigarette in the pocket of the coat hanging on his chair. After taking a long, deep breath, the man who was always full of energy was suddenly the epitome of he who is calm and collected. "Want a smoke?"

"You already know my answer."

The preacher shrugged as he lit it and took a couple long puffs. "You know, I never took the nanobot injections, Raphael. I'm as mortal as humans ought to be."

Raphael raised an eyebrow. "I always thought you were being hypocritical about most of what you preached. You genuinely didn't accept the injections?"

Clarence shook his head slowly, his entire demeanor almost seeming to be that of a different person. One more calm and focused than the loud brash personality he played up for the crowd. "I don't trust others, especially the government and anyone with authority over me. Certainly not you or your kind. This was supposed to be a scam that made me some money for a while... didn't expect to become a multi-millionaire and turn it into a career. But, more importantly..." Clarence's gaze drifted slightly to Raphael's side, as he seemed to zone out. "I'm getting old, Raphael. I'm in my 50's, you know. By the standards of the uninjected, that means my life is at least half over. I smoke, too. I'm very likely to die before I'm 75."

Raphael nodded slowly as he stared at the child before him. How amusing, that he would speak of half a century as 'old'. He knew so little about the true lengths that time could go to. "Your point?"

Clarence took a final drag on the cigarette before smashing it in an ashtray beside himself. "I have all this money, all these women, all this fame and power, but I feel... empty. It feels hollow. I'm going to die soon. I don't know when or how, but I can feel it coming. For once, I'm able to understand why so many took the easy path, accepting those damned nanobots into their bodies. What good is money and sex and fame if you won't live long enough to enjoy it?"

Raphael chuckled to himself. "Ah, so immortality is the solution, then? If you were immortal, you could enjoy it forever, you know."

"Could I? Are you sure?" Clarence's expression seemed haggard as he rubbed at his eyes. "A man tires of everything, if he does it for long enough. Eventually, the money and sex and booze wears thin. What am I left with then?"

The wise angel scratched his chin as he thought about the question. "You could instead look to bettering yourself. Perhaps learning to play an instrument? Maybe, if you were immortal, you might try some crazy thrills, like skydiving? There's plenty to do."

"And after that?" Clarence turned to stare into the timeless eyes of a man who saw all and knew all. "What happens when I've mastered every instrument, made love to every woman, eaten every type of food, seen every star, and done everything that life has to offer? What even makes any of those things worth pursuing?"

Raphael leaned forwards on the bench, feeling his interest piqued. "I've been alive for many billions of years, child. I am not yet bored. I still find many ways to enjoy myself."

"You are not human, you are an angel. Your brain is different from mine, even if only in small ways. You can't understand..." Clarence paused mid-sentence and shrugged. "I guess it really doesn't matter after all. Life is meaningless, from my viewpoint. Even if I could live forever, eventually I would tire of it and wish to die."

Raphael sighed as he stood up from his seat. This conversation was clearly going nowhere. "Get some rest, young man. Take a couple weeks off. The congregation will understand. You're no good to me dead, anyway. Clearly you need some rest and relaxation."

Clarence smiled slightly. "Is that pity in your voice? Fine, I'll take some time off. Maybe I'm just feeling overworked. I hope this dreadful feeling goes away soon, I don't like it one bit."

Raphael set his jaw as he walked out of the room. *Humans are so interesting sometimes. They can be so loud and boisterous, yet so full of melancholy and depression. Truly a river of unending emotions.*

Clarence stared at the bottle of pills before him as the archangel left the room. *What am I doing with my life?*

I teleported back down to Earth, glancing over at Amelia sheepishly, as she sat on the grass in the stadium and slowly tossed a baseball back and forth between her hands. "Err, hey."

"Took you long enough." She mumbled quietly as she refused to look at me, instead just staring at the baseball. She watched it slowly move from left, to right, to left, to right...

"Sorry, I just had something to take care of. I didn't forget you. I figured you might like the sunshine and grass, since we're almost always on the ship together."

Amelia nodded slowly. "Ah. So that was the reason. Very convincing." I felt my face flinch at her tone. She didn't sound convinced.

I stood there, hands on my hips, as I stared at her silently for a few moments. "All right, I messed up. I don't know what to say... I'm sorry. Forgive me?"

Amelia smiled slightly, but shoved it back down. She seemed to be forcing herself to look angry, or annoyed or something. Secretly though, I decided she was actually trying to hide a case of the giggles. I probably looked hilarious moping about.

"What is there to forgive? You were busy. It's okay if you just want to ditch me to go have some fun by yourself. I don't matter that much anyway."

I felt a groan bubbling up from within myself. *Women.*

"Come on, that's not fair. Especially after I just found out one of my clones has been cloning world leaders behind my back for over a year now. He's got pods full of them. I didn't leave to go play games, I left for business reasons." *Err, sort of. Actually, I can't remember why I went to the JIB. Maybe it was just nerves because I wanted to get out of there quickly after my speech.*

Amelia finally broke into a smile as she tossed the ball to the side and jumped up from the grass. "Really? They made clones of other people?! I didn't know you could do that!"

Ah, she's such an airhead sometimes. Seems she's already forgotten why she was mad. "Yeah, I can, but it's highly unethical and I haven't done it in well over a century. In fact, I didn't ever do it myself. Only my clones ever seem to do it."

Amelia hemmed and hawed for a moment. "So, err, could you make a clone of me, then?"

I scratched my head. "I mean... yeah. Why would I, though? You're right here."

Amelia mumbled something to herself as she looked away from me for a moment. "So, if you clone me... does Levvy get cloned too?"

I frowned as I found myself questioning that too. "I... don't know. Hmm. I don't really want to try though, no offense. The thing about clones is that once they're around, you can't get rid of them. Or rather, I can't. I mean, I can, but it feels just wrong. If I'm going to deliberately create a life, I can't just kill it off ever, you know?"

Amelia scowled at me. "Why would you even think such a thing? You mean if you cloned me, it might actually pass through your thick head that the clone needed to be killed? Clones are people too, Jason!"

I grimaced. "Yeah, I know that. What I'm saying is that in the future, I had to do that once. I had to kill every clone of myself that I made. I reabsorbed them into my body, and their mental wails of anguish... stuck around inside me for a long time. I never want to do that again. I only make a clone now if I'm resolute their existence will never come to an end at my own hand, not without a good reason."

Amelia's frown faded away as she nodded. "Yeah, but aren't you forgetting something? If you clone me, you can have twice as much of my love! We can have lots of... *fun*." She inflected carefully on that last word, making me cock an eyebrow.

"I'm not so sure. I think you would get jealous of your other half. You might start thinking I was spending too much time with her, and then I might have trouble telling you apart from her. Too many bad things could happen."

Amelia shrugged. "Hey, your loss. Anyway, now that you mention it, why not get one of your clones down here one of these nights? Then we can really get down to business!"

I chortled to myself, while also feeling slightly grossed out by the thought. *This girl can be downright freaky and weird sometimes.*

"It's a neat thought, but let's hold off. I see what you're getting at, but don't you think all my other clones would feel left out?"

"Oh. You've got a point there." Amelia nodded quickly as she seemed to figure out some intricate puzzle the universe had set before her. " *Anyway*, if you ever happen to want to clone me, let me know! I'd have a real blood sister for once! Like a twin or something!"

"I don't think that's how it works." I put my hand on her shoulder as I set my mind on a beach some miles away from the east side of London. "Come on, let's go have some fun. It's been a while since we just hung out on Earth, you know?"

She nodded emphatically as I wordsmithed once again. " **Teleport.** "

"I don't git it, Davook. What good's this gonna do?" Torlok stared at the dynamite in his hands, being careful not to shake it, given he had been warned it was an especially volatile type, and he didn't like the sound of that.

"Look here, kid. That hotel over there has 5,000 humans in it. We bomb it, then set 'er on fire, then we get outta here. Don't ask questions, just do what needs to be done." Davook stood up slightly, peering out of his bush at the brightly lit beach, and all the humans frolicking and playing around so carefree. "Gods, humans are ugly. I don't know how they manage to make babies when every one of 'em looks worse than the smelly side of my ass."

"Sheit, you've got a face only a broodmother could love. You shouldn't be judging, Davook." Torlok tittered to himself, even as he kept his gaze warily on the sticks in his hands.

"Shut up, dumbass. Alright, the coast is clear, let's get a move on." Davook quickly stepped out of the bushes, keeping low as he hid in the shadow of a 3 foot seawall, his shadow-walking abilities barely doing much in the brightness of the midday sun. "Satan must hate me. That's why he wants us to do this while Sol is up there lookin' down on us all."

Torlok sprinted up behind him and they both crouched low, following the sea wall until they reached the gap where they'd have to run past and hope no humans saw them. This beach resort was a busy location, and especially given the prime location in eastern Britannia, not far from the outskirts of London itself. An attack this close to the capital city hadn't been attempted in half a decade. This would really make the fleshbags fearful.

Davook froze, as he cursed under his breath. "A human is coming."

Torlok stayed perfectly still as they both activated their full shadow walking abilities, becoming nearly invisible, as a single man in swimming trunks sauntered over to the wall, looking all around carefully as he shot a glance over to the outhouses, both of which were presently occupied.

"God gave me the equipment, I don't need a stall for this." He walked within a few feet of the shadow-walkers, totally oblivious to their presence as he pulled his 'gun' out and quickly took a leak while nobody was watching. Within a few seconds, he was finished as he whistled merrily, putting his weapon away and going on his way back down to the beach front.

Davook snarled silently, stewing for a few moments as he glared at the disgusting puddle mere feet away from his face. "If I ever get my hands on that sunnofa-" He bit his lip, cutting himself off as he used his energy to shadow-walk to the other side of the gap, teleporting to its shadow in the blink of an eye. Torlok appeared behind him a moment later.

Unfortunately, Torlok couldn't stop snickering to himself. "Heh heh, too bad his aim was off. I told ya you looked like a dump, Davook! He probably smelled a toilet and thought you were the designated-"

Davook didn't even pause as he reached back around and violently backhanded his chuckling companion. "Laugh it up, shit for brains. Next time, I'll mash your face in it, then we'll see how funny you think it is."

Torlok's laughter had already stopped as he rubbed the spot where Davook had smacked him. "Yer a real jerk sometimes."

The two of them moved on silently after that, neither of them speaking to each other. Within a minute or two, they had arrived near the outside of the hotel. In the distance, the sound of a crowd at the hotel's massive swimming pool was audible as they too frolicked and played. "Humans are so damn carefree. This oughta shake them up." Davook reached into his own bag, pulling out some napalm charges, designed to start extremely hot fires, very quickly. "I'll plant these around the building. You go stick those on the roof. If we're lucky, it might collapse the entire building on the fleshbags inside."

Torlok chuckled. "Make sure all the doorways are on fire. Then the humans won't be able to get out so easy."

"No shit, stupid. You think I'm a moron or somethin'? I'm the brains of this operation. Now get going." Davook took off, pressing himself against the wall of the building as he made his way to the main entrance.

Torlok quickly jumped up, jamming his claws and feet into the brick siding, easily scaling it like there had already been footholds made for him. Just thirty stories separated him from the top, and soon, a lot of humans were going to die.

The young demon licked his lips as he scaled the wall. Even if the humans on the beach saw him now, it was too late. Their fate was sealed.

Part 331a:

Amelia grins intently as she puts the finishing touches on her sand-castle. "It's perfect! Looks just like a place I lived in for a few decades!"

I stare in awe at the three-foot tall monstrosity. "How are you so good at making these? It's like you were born to form sand."

Amelia giggles at me as she takes a few steps back to admire her creation. "I'm actually quite artistic, I'll have you know! I studied under a few prominent humans, way back in the day."

"Interesting." I start to ask who they were, but then Amelia winds her foot back, leaping forwards and blasting her castle to pieces in a single blow as a terrific blast of wind surges outwards from where she had kicked. Sometimes I forgot about just how powerful she is. "Whoa! You destroyed it, after all that work?!"

Amelia shrugs as she walks around, knocking over a few leftover lumps with her heel. "The ocean would have done that anyway." She flicks her eyes from here to there, taking note of all the people milling about on the beach. Several couples are walking hand in hand, while children laugh and play in the shallow water nearby. The sun blasts down, heating the nearby beach to an uncomfortable ninety degrees Fahrenheit. Still, at least it isn't a hundred.

"It's getting hot out here." I bring up the weather like it's important and she hasn't already noticed.

"It's been like this because of the climate shifts. A massive dust cloud in the Americas after the demons wiped them out, plus a nuclear bombing a decade ago. It was inevitable." Amelia wipes at her face and glances down, seeing the sweat on her brow. We're both wearing just swimwear, so it's about the least dressed we can be, barring full nudity.

"I'm surprised you know about that stuff. I remember teaching you how to play chess and you didn't know what it was, yet now you understand climate shifting."

Amelia shoots a dirty look at me. "I'm not dumb, Jason! I was just uninformed. I'm actually quite intelligent, I'll have you know!" She pauses for a moment as a mischievous grin spreads across her face. "Hmm, say, Jason... I think you need to cool off!"

I blink as suddenly she appears at my side with lightning fast speed, her hands pressing into my ribcage as I suddenly feel myself being thrown from my standing position out into the ocean nearby. In the span of two seconds, I smash into the water with enough force to kill any normal

human. With my high regeneration abilities and incredibly strong body though, it merely knocks the wind out of me, as I quickly swim back up to the surface, gasping for air.

"You s-scared the crap out of me!" I sputter and stammer as I stare forwards, realizing she sent me flying over a hundred feet with the barest of effort. The beach is now a short distance away.

Dog paddling my way towards the beach, I feel a slight embarrassment at the fact I'm neither the greatest nor the most graceful swimmer in the world. Amelia is chuckling to herself as I near the beach. "You should have seen your face! That was pricel-"

She's suddenly cut off as a massive explosion sounds off in the distance behind her, followed by several more in the span of a few seconds. My eyes immediately jerk towards the source of the blast, as I feel shock surge through my body. A nearby hotel is being blown to pieces, and it doesn't look like any sort of scheduled demolition. People are screaming in the distance and I can see groups of people fleeing in panic.

Amelia turns back and gawks at it. "Jason! That hotel is being attacked!" A master of the obvious, that girl is.

" **Teleport.** " I decide to take the fast route to the shore, rather than swimming. " **Dry.** " My entire body suddenly feels as if I've never experienced the feeling of water in my life, almost making me feel like I'm in a desert. Oh well.

"Amelia, stay here. I'm going to go see what's going on!" I start to move forwards but she grabs my arm.

"No! I'm coming with you!" She seems annoyed that I'd even consider leaving her behind, and it occurs to me that she's right. If she can take a beating from my hypersuit, she'll be fine.

"Alright. Let's change into something more appropriate." I take a step back, quickly glancing over at the Hotel a few football fields away. " **Storage. Wear. Wear.** " I pull her outfit from storage as well as mine out, making us both wear them in an instant. She's now wearing a cute little blue dress, as she likes to do, while I'm wearing my suit from my speech earlier. Not ideal, but whatever. "Let's go." I place my hand on her shoulder. " **Teleport.** "

* * *

We jump over to the hotel and arrive in the midst of chaos. Flames have rapidly engulfed the bottom two floors, and the smell of death is in the air. I immediately spot a woman trying to crawl across the ground, as a trail of blood is left behind her. Based on the window that was smashed out nearby, she must have broken it, climbed out, and cut herself up in the process. "Amelia, go help her. I'll take care of the rest."

She nods and runs off to heal the woman, as I feel a slight twinge of fear. The sight of blood... if anything is going to bring out the old Amelia, that would be it.

...No. Amelia is different now. I can't think like that. If she does anything, it will be the last bad thing she ever does. But I trust her, just as she trusts me.

Turning my gaze back to the hotel, I quickly wordsmith. " **Extinguish.** "

Nothing seems to happen, but then I notice the spot I was looking at had the flames disappear for a moment. I'm simply not using enough power. " **EXTINGUISH!** "

In a flash, an entire section of the hotel suddenly stops being ablaze, the fires vanishing in an instant, though more of the hotel is still on fire. I decide now is a good time to increase my mobility. " **Hypersuit. Wear.** " As my suit appears around my body, feeling especially uncomfortable because of the black suit I'm wearing under it, I grunt and ignore the discomfort. These people have it far worse.

Quickly dashing around the building, I continue wordsmithing. " **EXTINGUISH! EXTINGUISH! EXTINGUISH!** "

Finally, the fires are out, but the heat in the air is still palpable. I jump twenty stories upward in a single bound, jamming my hands into the wall before leaping the remaining ten up onto the roof. The roof is in shambles, with the majority of it sunken in. It looks a lot like bombs were planted up here, then detonated. This had to be some sort of terrorist act.

Quickly I aim my hand at the center of the roof. " **WATER! WATER! WATER!** " A small flood appears, surging downwards from the spot it appeared at, blasting through stairwells and down into elevator shafts as I keep summoning the water. Finally I pause, waiting a few seconds until I see the water rushing out of windows on each floor. I feel a sudden bit of regret, realizing it might have washed people out of the windows too, but it can't be helped. My goal was to quickly cool off the building, possibly sucking some of the smoke out too.

"Centurion, scan the building below me. How many survivors are there?"

An image appears on the viewscreen before me as Centurion quickly follows my orders. "PILOT JASON HIRO, MY SCAN INDICATES THAT ROUGHLY SEVEN HUNDRED HUMANS ARE EITHER ALIVE OR LIGHTLY INJURED, WHILE THREE THOUSAND TWO HUNDRED ARE DECEASED OR IN CRITICAL CONDITION."

I hear a sound in the distance as ambulances and firefighters rush towards the scene. "Great, we've done enough. Centurion, any theories as to who might have done this?"

Centurion responds after a few moments. "INFORMATION INSUFFICIENT. MORE DATA REQUIRED TO CREATE A THEORY REGARDING THE PERPETRATORS."

I grimace. That's an awful lot of words just to say he didn't know. Oh well, he's a relatively clunky AI anyway. Speaking of which, I haven't heard from Umi in forever. She no longer responds when I call for her, and she hasn't spoken to me in years. Where the hell has she gone off to?

Jumping off the building, I fall thirty stories and smash into the ground below, the hypersuit absorbing the impact easily. I had almost forgotten just how powerful this suit made me feel. "**Remove.**" I strip the suit off with a single word and pack it back in my storage, then glance around and spot Amelia again.

Something isn't right, though. Amelia is sobbing uncontrollably, and she's slumped over in front of the woman I left her with before. Oh... oh no... what if she...

I quickly run over, relief flooding my face as I see the woman's body is perfectly intact. However, she's completely still now. She seems to be dead.

"Amelia? Are you okay? What happened?" I kneel down and put my hand on her back, even as she chokes back another sob.

"I'm s-sorry Jason! I couldn't save her! I couldn't heal her! She died! It's my fault!" Amelia is almost screaming, she's so overcome with grief.

I quickly pull her to my chest and hug her, staring uneasily at the woman laying motionless on the ground. "It's okay, you did what you could."

"It wasn't enough! She died because I was too weak, Jason! She... she even begged me to save her..." Amelia continues to cry as the firefighters and EMT's arrive on scene.

Damn. I didn't think it would come out like this. Amelia had healed me in the future when my entire body was shattered to pieces. Maybe she still wasn't very adept at it yet. I stared at the body carefully, even while Amelia averted her eyes. She seemed unable to look at it, probably because of guilt.

There was a lot of blood on the sidewalk around us, and where the sidewalk turned into sand, it was thick and very dark brown. The woman had probably lost a lot of blood. As Amelia sobbed, I gently used my telekinesis to rotate the body a little bit so I could get a look at the woman's frontside. She was covered in blood, but a huge shard of glass was sticking out of her stomach, the wound closed around it perfectly, though blood appeared to be slowly leaking outwards now that I had shifted her weight somewhat.

That explains it. Amelia healed the body, but she didn't replace the blood loss, and she left a foreign object inside. That glass shard might have had pathogens on it too, infecting the wound. Amelia still had a lot to learn, after all.

I stood up, as Amelia also rose up weakly, her knees shaking in grief. "It's not your fault, Amelia. You did the best you could. It's my fault for not training you well enough. This woman's death is on my hands."

She nodded slowly, though her face betrayed that she didn't believe me. Words are cheap anyway, we'll simply both have to feel guilty.

Oddly, I didn't feel a single shred of sadness bubble up. I almost felt like I didn't even care about the woman's death.

So strange. Amelia was crying over a dead human, but I wasn't. Wasn't she supposed to be the heartless monster here?

I put my hand on her shoulder again, swallowing stiffly as I turned to stare back at the devastated hotel behind me. " **Return.** "

"Oh my god..." Amy gasped at the live story developing on the news. A resort had been attacked by terrorists, and a message scrawled in blood on the front entrance stated that the demons had done it. *More will come.* The message had stated plain as day that the demons had no intention of stopping their assault on the humans.

Jorge walked in from the back room, where he had been working on a vintage muscle car from the previous century. It was built in a time before fusion-powered hover generators existed. He was actually younger than Amy by about twenty years, so he had grown up around hovercraft, only in the last few years getting into old-style vehicles for fun during his leisure time.

"What happened? He turned and stared at the wall viewscreen, frowning as the location scrolled across the screen at the bottom. "Christ, that isn't even fifty miles away. I thought we were winning. Is this the cost of losing another Supreme Commander in such a short time?"

Amy felt the shock dissipate slightly as she continued watching the news coverage. "Almost three quarters of the guests at the hotel died. That's crazy! The demons are pure evil." She paused for a moment, as she turned away from the screen, unable to look as the news flashed onto some brutally injured survivors who were being rushed into ambulances. "If the new Supreme Commander, Jason, can't control the demons and start dealing some real damage, we're in for a world of hurt."

"They got past our defensive forces. Impressive, if you ask me. I've seen some of the tech we employ now. We can even detect when they open a portal within the monitoring zones." Jorge scratched his chin as he shrugged. "They must have sneaked past the detection machines on foot, instead of just creating a portal for a hit and run. That's real dedication, and judging by the damage, it was successful too."

Jorge and Amy both stared at each other uncomfortably for a few moments as they thought about the implications of this. If the demons were able to evade the detectors somehow, they might be able to hit a target much closer to home. These were dangerous times.

"You know, Sarah is getting older now. I've been thinking about getting back to the work for the military, now that Stonewall and Benjamin are gone." Amy bit her lip as she felt Jorge's gaze searching her.

"You want back in, huh? I should have seen it coming. It's not just because you think the new commander is a hunk, right?" Jorge felt a playful grin creep over his face as his wife returned the expression back at him.

"Oh come on, it's not like that! Anyway, I just want to help. If more people die and I could have helped prevent their deaths, somehow, then I'll end up feeling guilty."

She spoke earnestly and Jorge smiled at her lovingly, as he considered her opinion. "Well, if you really want to, you can. There is, of course, another way you might be able to help."

"Oh?" Amy cocked an eyebrow at her husband as she waited expectantly for him to elaborate.

"That big mega-church. We could start attending it. You and I both know it helps give energy to the angels, which might be crucial if we ever need their assistance fighting the demonic threat. I don't really agree with everything the church preaches, but it couldn't hurt to go and listen to what they have to say."

Amy rolled her eyes. "Church, huh?" Her smile flattened out as boredom took over. "Jorge, I'm an atheist. So are you. We both know the angels are flawed beings that seek to use humans for cattle. Why would you ever suggest helping them? They're hardly better than the demons."

"I don't see it that way at all." Jorge countered, as he felt an argument coming on. "The angels serve a purpose, sweetheart. They aren't perfect, and they may in fact be using us, but they *need* us. They can't ever truly become the enemy of humanity, given if they kill us off, they will die too. They're allies of ours simply because they have no choice. And they are quite strong allies too. Russia was once a threat to the world, but then they gave us great aid during the titanic battles with the Volgrim. I don't think it's so black and white."

Amy started to retort, but paused. "You always say the oddest things. Still, you have a point..." She glanced over at the TV, feeling a pain in her chest as corpses were shown being wrapped in white body bags. "I don't really trust angels or gods, but at least they haven't done anything to directly hurt humanity. Maybe we should start going."

"That's the spirit." Jorge smiled as a wave of relief washed over him. No argument this time. They didn't even argue all that much, and were fairly loving and harmonious towards each other in general, but still... when they did, it was unpleasant. "Anyway, Sarah has baseball practice later. You want me to take her?"

"No, that's fine. You have work tomorrow. Don't want you falling asleep on the job." Amy giggled as she walked over and kissed her husband passionately, rubbing her hands all over his back. "Shoot, now you've got me thinking about that new Supreme Commander. I'm feeling kind of frisky."

Jorge rolled his eyes as a huge grin spread across his face. "You're such a tease."

Part 332a:

I calmly wait for a few moments as the replicator crafts the molecules together to make myself a fresh cup of coffee. Amelia is sitting on the other side of the kitchen in one of the few easy chairs we had set up, staring out blankly into space. Her expression is... pained. That woman's death really hit her hard.

The replicator lets out a soft 'ding' as the coffee appears on the plate, and I walk over to where she's sitting, gently placing myself across from her as I take a long sip of the delicious java.

"You can't keep beating yourself up over this." I stare at her evenly as she continues to look out the window, deliberately avoiding my gaze.

"It's my fault she died, Jason. All I've ever done is kill, and the one time I had the chance to heal someone, I failed. It was within my power, but I was careless." Amelia isn't crying or anything, she spent all of her tears earlier. For a nearly immortal demigoddess of sorts, she could be a fairly emotional being when something hit her hard.

"It was a simple mistake. I've made mistakes too, you know. Bad ones. Magic isn't infallible... I learned that a long time ago."

"I know that, Jason. I'm not sad that I didn't save her, I'm sad that it was well within my power to save her and my carelessness is what killed her. If it was simply a matter of... of her being in an irredeemable state, then I'd have to swallow my pain and accept it. But..." Amelia finally turns to stare at me, her eyes betraying no emotion. "...but I can't forgive myself for this. Even more so, I can't forgive the demons. They attacked that hotel and killed all those people. They're monsters."

I nod along with her words. "Demons are mostly pure evil. I've met a few good ones, but the majority of them hate humans, whether for rational or irrational reasons. To be fair, humans hate the demons too, but still, two wrongs don't make a right." I feel a sudden pain in my chest as I remember Gregory, and Samantha... two demons who I once considered to be my close friend and lover, respectively. How long has it been since I spoke to Samantha? It's been over a hundred years since I arrived back in the past, an infinitely long time in human terms. I can barely even remember the taste of her skin, or the softness of her lips. Her face has been slowly fading from my memory...

Ah, yes, Cassiel. Her too. I loved both of them so much, but it feels like an eternity has passed. Amelia is here now. Do I need them anymore? Do I really need to protect the future

they come from? Isn't it already too late to see them again?

I suddenly realize Amelia is staring at me intently. "You were off in your own little world there for a minute. Something on your mind?"

"Sorry, just thinking about the future again. I'm beginning to wonder if I should just do what I can to save the world entirely, kill all the demons, and unite humanity. If all the demons are dead, the future I come from won't exist anymore. It's that simple."

Amelia nods sagely as she turns again to stare out at the stars of the Milky Way all around us. "Time is a fickle thing. I've been reading a lot of books and watching some vintage old movies about time travel. There are a lot of theories about paradoxes and stuff like that. Aren't you worried you'll erase yourself?"

"I think we're well past that threshold." I take another sip of my coffee as I brood quietly. "I'm still not sure how time travel works. Is the Grandfather Paradox relevant? The Butterfly Effect? Multiverse theory? I just don't have enough information. Perhaps... Umi..."

I catch myself as Amelia tilts her head to look at me oddly. "Umi? Who's that?"

"A friend of mine, but we haven't spoken in a long time. She's been oddly secretive and quiet lately, I'm not sure why."

Amelia glares at me suspiciously. "Another woman, then? Do I need to be worried? Judging by her name, she sounds like an ugly sea hag."

"Err, it's not like that at all. She's kind of like a smart person I can ask questions, and she always knows the answer." I feel myself weirded out by the thought of being in love with an artificial intelligence. How would that even work, anyway? Maybe if she made a robot body... no, wait, please stop. These thoughts are making me ill.

Amelia smiles faintly as she glances at my coffee enviously. "It's fine, you could never love another woman more than you love me. I'm the perfect girl, after all."

I raise an eyebrow at her rather cocky statement. "Perfect, huh? You have a pretty high opinion of yourself."

"I'm the most powerful woman in existence, so it's only natural." Amelia's smile widens as she flips back her three-foot long raven black hair, tossing it around with a flourish. "Other women would be lucky to have a tenth of my beauty, let alone my power."

"I beat you in combat though, so I'm more powerful than you." I point at her and wink, which makes her smile falter.

"Oh please, that was a long time ago. You managed to hit me one time, and I've been working on my skills in the holodeck when you're away. You'd be lucky to get past first base the

next time we spar." Amelia rolls her eyes as she looks back out at the stars dreamily.

"Doesn't really matter, as a man, I'd be ashamed if I had to hit the woman I love. It wouldn't be a fair fight either way."

"The words of a scaredy-cat. Suit yourself! I'd rather put my abilities to use fighting the demons anyway. I..." Amelia's expression darkened as she seemed to remember the woman once again. "...I want to kill them, Jason. What they did wasn't right. It was mindless slaughter, like what I used to do. It has to stop, or the cycle of violence will never come to an end."

Amelia... she was so serious sometimes. What a dramatic shift her personality was like now compared to just twenty years ago. She kind of reminded me of an alcoholic or a smoker in recovery. Once the addiction has been weaned, a strange hatred for the substance appears, causing the former addict to react violently to the thought of returning to their original sick lifestyle.

Is that what was going on with her? Perhaps she so loathed the thought of killing and devouring humans that her failure to save that woman was eating her alive. The guilt must be... mind-boggling. The only solution I can think of is allowing her a chance to properly heal someone for once. Perhaps that would repair this newly created mental scar.

"I agree, Amelia. The demons need to be stopped... at all costs. It's time to go on the offensive, and win this time. No more pussyfooting around... we need to kill them and capture Satan. With the hydra's head gone, the rest of the body will fall."

Amelia smiled at me again, this time with a more soft and sincere feeling. "I don't want to kill anymore, Jason, but it has to be done. I'm not doing it for you, but for me."

"That's for the best."

The three members of the family felt rather out of place in this megachurch, but the other members of the church were quite welcoming. An older lady strode forwards, a somewhat false smile spread across her face. "Welcome to the Church of Retribution! Have you come to hear Father Clarence's sermon today?"

Jorge glanced at Amy and nodded stiffly. "Uh, yeah." He couldn't imagine any other reason they would be there, given they were new members. It sounded like such a dumb question, but he didn't want to be impolite.

"Splendid! Simply wonderful! This is a special sermon that you're going to hear today, one sure to excite you as newcomers! Come along with me, now! It's starting in just a few minutes!" The grey haired old woman nodded excitedly as she tittered about, quickly walking through the main lobby and through a massive set of double doors into an incredibly huge auditorium.

Jorge, Amy, and Sarah all followed along with a bit of hesitation in their steps, but they figured it was best to just go with the flow. It would be rude to leave now.

As the doors opened, Sarah gasped. A crowd the likes of which she had never seen in her entire life milled about, cheering and whooping loudly as they held their bibles high and stared at a stage that stretched out into the crowd, with a circular platform for Clarence to stand on when he arrived.

Having arrived so late, they were forced to stand near the doors, though personally Jorge and Amy didn't mind, given they would be able to leave more easily than if they were being pressed forwards by standing closer to the stage. The crowd seemed excitable, but polite. No real shoving or anger took place, and all the people around them had broad smiles on their faces as they waited anxiously for the Father to arrive.

The old woman, having shown them the auditorium, hurried away quickly before they could ask her anything. Jorge groaned. "Is this really a good idea? It's not too late to leave."

Amy shrugged. "Worst case scenario, we waste an hour of our lives. There are bigger things we could be wasting time on right now, and this indirectly helps Earth."

"Yeah, I know that. I just..." Jorge cut himself off as a hush descended over the crowd.

The lights dimmed as a huge spotlight lit up the red curtains in the distance. A man quickly strode out, his dark skin contrasting with the pure white robes he wore, illuminated even more brightly by the spotlight aimed at him.

"My children, I am here for you!" The crowd erupted in cheers as Father Clarence walked with purpose to the center of the auditorium, raising his hands up to the sky as if to accept god's love personally. "I have once again spoken with the angels, and they have told me of the great impact we are having on Earth! Already, we have a new Supreme Commander instated, one who is friendly to the angels and people of our faith! Rejoice, for he is going to be a new agent of change! The Messiah!"

Some people seemed confused that a Supreme Commander was suddenly an ally, but they quickly overcame their misgivings and cheered wildly. Jorge shot a questioning glance at his wife, but she merely shrugged, as she usually did in situations like these.

"This is no ordinary Supreme Commander! I have been assured by the angels themselves that he is one who saved their very existence, single-handedly! A mighty warrior, born of the cloth, with powers granted by the angels! He alone has the power to win this war on behalf of those on high!" Clarence's voice rose and fell, like a wave crashing onto the beach, his fever infecting those nearest him and spreading outwards from there.

Jorge was beginning to feel disillusioned, but before he could say something negative, he glanced down to see his daughter hopping giddily as she tried to see over the crowd. "Wow, he's so cool! I want to be a holy warrior too!"

Jorge chuckled, but then felt an odd sense of dread. This was how the indoctrination started, by infecting the minds of those who were too young to know right from wrong. He'd have to talk with her when they got home.

"Imagine, my children, the strength it must take to fight on behalf of those on high! It is a lonely battle... one that pays little but the riches one will receive when they pass into the next world. Truly, Jason Hiro is a Supreme Commander unlike his predecessors! We should use him as an example for ourselves, cloaking ourselves in the humble spirit required to follow the commands of those who reign in Heaven!"

Jorge finally groaned and rubbed his eyes, reaching over to touch his wife's arm. "Come on, Amy. Let's go. I've had enough of this."

Amy continued to stare at the man onstage, resisting Jorge's efforts to pull her away. "I know you don't like him much, but I'm going to stay here with Sarah for a bit. We'll be out soon, alright?"

Jorge felt an odd sensation in his chest as his wife continued to stare at the bellowing man on the platform a hundred feet away. Was she really interested in what this lunatic had to say? Perhaps she was just curious. She'd been an atheist as long as they had been together. Best to not pressure her one way or another.

"Fine, I'll be outside waiting. Just make sure you get out before the sermon is over, or you'll have to fight the crowd."

Amy nodded absentmindedly. "Yeah. Uh-huh. Sure." A smile broke out on her face from out of nowhere as the preacher screamed into the microphone once again, the sound making Jorge feel physically ill. Tearing himself away from his wife and daughter, he shook his head slowly as he headed back outside.

Women. You can marry one and live with her for twenty years, and she'll still surprise you. Jorge grimaced as he ambled out to their hovercar in the parking lot. Hopefully, this wouldn't take them too much longer. He was in dire need of an aspirin.

Part 333a:

April 28th, 2117

The men and women in the room waited patiently, despite the fact the new Supreme Commander was already fifteen minutes late. Sitting in rows of aluminum chairs, the varying assortment of generals, lieutenants, scientists, and analysts numbered nearly two hundred, and Jorge was just one man among many who were going to meet the new Supreme Commander for the first time.

Amy sat next to him as the two of them felt their legs tapping up and down rapidly, adrenaline coursing through their veins.

"I can't believe I'm going to see him again." Amy mumbled to herself nervously, as Jorge glanced over at her and put his hand on hers.

"Don't be nervous. I mean, he probably won't remember you at all. Heck, it's unlikely that you'll even get a chance to speak with him." Jorge immediately rained on her parade which dulled her excitement somewhat.

She pulled her hand away and glared at him playfully. "I hear jealousy in your voice. Afraid a big strong man like him is going to sweep me off my feet?"

"Unlikely. Besides, I'm sure given his looks he's got a harem of women, assuming he can ever find the time." Jorge grinned sarcastically at his wife, but she seemed to take him seriously.

"You think so? I guess that would make sense."

"It's a joke. Jeez, Amy, calm yourself down. He's probably-" Jorge paused as the door suddenly swished open and a hush fell across the room. He was getting tired of being cut off like that.

Three men and two women walked in, all of them being four star generals, followed by the Supreme Commander himself, Jason Hiro.

"All rise and salute the Supreme Commander." A woman at the front of the room spoke and jerked her hand up stiffly, as the entire audience rose to their feet in the blink of an eye and followed suit. A moment later, they all sat back down again and waited eagerly.

"Hey, everyone, nice to meet you all." The Supreme Commander spoke rather informally, seeming to ignore general formal speech in favor of something friendlier. "I'm Jason Hiro, though to keep things succinct, you may refer to me as Mr. Hiro during this briefing. Today we're going to be looking over data from the last few decades to formulate a strategy for

eliminating the demons within the next few years. All suggestions will be considered. Additionally, we're going to look at travel to other worlds for the purpose of creating secondary places for humanity to survive in the case of a huge catastrophe on Earth. Can't hurt to be safe."

"Mr. Hiro, are you saying there's still a chance Earth could suffer a major attack?" One of the analysts in the front row fired off a question, and Jason pivoted to respond.

"Anything can happen. Even barring an attack, there's always the threat of an asteroid hitting earth, or a comet, or perhaps nuclear war, so we have to think of threats beyond just the demons and Volgrim. Let's move on."

Jason turned back to face the viewscreen at the front as a series of bars and graphs appeared showing various factoids. "Humanity has been remarkably efficient in the art of war. We've lost under a million soldiers over the last hundred years, and the bulk of those we did lose were due to battles with the Volgrim in space. On the ground, the Hypersuit Commandos were effectively unstoppable, doling out death in the tens of millions to demons and Volgrim alike. I have concluded that our ground forces are doing a fantastic job, even when we're in the lair of the enemy and in unfamiliar territory."

Jason paused for a moment as uncertainty crossed over his face. "As you all know, I am from the future. In the future I come from, I lived in the labyrinth and fought the demons for well over a decade. A curious fact about the labyrinth then and now is that in the future I come from, its paths shift, whereas here in this time, they are static. This has given us a great boon in that we have fully mapped out over twenty percent of its corridors." Despite the fact he was giving good news, Mr. Hiro seemed suspicious of something, but he didn't elaborate.

"The fact we have mapped out a fifth of the enemy's world gives us lots of strategic options. I would like to establish forward bases and teleportation rooms inside their lair, while simultaneously focusing on eliminating their presence on Earth. Additionally, I am planning to deploy nuclear weapons inside the labyrinth, deep inside where our own forces will be unaffected. My own clones will be the ones to do this with the aid of Hypersuits."

Jason Hiro's comments on nuclear weapons made the entire audience start chattering to each other quietly, some people murmuring about whether such a thing would be a good idea. One researcher spoke up, deciding to air his thoughts. "Commander, with all due respect, wouldn't nuclear weapons be rather ineffective inside the labyrinth, given that it's essentially half the size of planet Earth itself? Do we even know if this will be more than a blip on the radar compared to the vast number of demons inside?"

Jason shrugged, a move that made other members of the audience give him looks of hesitation. "Honestly, the size of the labyrinth is half the size of Earth, but because the whole

thing is essentially a hollow maze of corridors and rooms for gestation and breeding of demons, it probably has the same surface area as Earth, maybe more. Keep in mind I'm not talking about a few nuclear weapons, but many. Easily a hundred will be dropped in key locations. I'm going to strategically target key chokepoints and heavily traversed passages to try and limit their movement. If we kill a few million of the bastards, or even more, it was a productive move."

"Do we know how many demons are inside the labyrinth?" A woman on the other side of the room wearing military garb spoke up.

"Billions. I can't even get a good estimated number, because we don't know what 80% of the labyrinth looks like. I do know though that the number is more than the sum of humanity's lives, so let that fact haunt you at night." Jason licked his lips as he glanced back around at the audience. "Anyway, beyond killing the demons, we need to look into repurposing other planets for humanity's use. Trifrancium will be needed to rapidly explore and colonize the nearby parts of the galaxy, and we need to find a steady source of it among nearby stars. In fact..."

Jason paused and looked around the audience for a moment, as if searching for someone. "I think there's someone here today that found such a likely planet. I, ah, forgot her name though." He scratched his head for moment as a look of embarrassment crossed his face. Amy quickly stood up and smiled.

"That would be me, Amy Gutierrez. A pleasure to, err, see you again, Supreme Commander." She felt her face redden as his eyes met hers.

"Oh, sorry, we've met before? Shoot, I don't mean to be rude but..." Jason paused for a moment, and Amy was about to elaborate, but then he cocked his head slightly, as if listening to an unknown informant. "Aha, now I remember. It just came back to me all of a sudden. You were on the moon base, decades ago, and were one of the pilots who helped protect us from the Volgrim. Based on the tiny bit of information I've seen in your profile, you seem to have had quite the illustrious career." He beckoned for her to step forwards.

As she did, she blushed again and indicated Jorge, sitting beside her. "This is my husband, Jorge. He was on a separate mission to explore the galaxy in the third quadrant."

Jason's eyes lit up for a moment. "Oh, yes. You didn't find any planets that would be immediately suitable for life, but I was informed you did find several planets ideal for mining, some which might contain Trifrancium. Both of you, come on up here."

Amy shot a glance at her husband who returned a smile to her. They quickly stood and walked up front.

Jorge swallowed as he approached the blonde mountain of a man. In person, he was only slightly less intimidating than Stonewall, who Jorge had never actually spoken to but had seen

several times in the past. Jason seemed like Stonewall's superior in the physical department though, as his body looked to be made of 250 pounds of solid muscle.

"Alright, I'd like to hear your thoughts on the planet you discovered, Mrs. Gutierrez. I've already looked at the reports regarding it carefully, but I want to hear your opinion as head of the expedition that discovered it."

Jason stared at Amy expectantly and she felt her heart racing slightly. "W-well, it was high in nitrogen and carbon dioxide concentration, and totally barren of course, but given your ability to terraform planets I assumed that you might be able to make it habitable. We found only trace amounts of oxygen, and very little hydrogen, so I'm not really even sure it was as big of a discovery as my team thought..."

Her voice trailed off as she felt her hands shaking slightly. She suddenly became acutely aware that she was standing in front of a crowd of two hundred onlookers, which only made her shaking more obvious. Jason, however, seemed to be completely oblivious.

"I can work with that. The most important thing is distance to the star. If the planet is in the habitation zone, I can remake everything about it as needed. I simply don't have the power to create an entire planet by itself though, so your discovery was the most important of all our expedition teams. You should feel proud of yourself!"

Amy felt her body warm up slightly at his words of praise, as well as the fact her husband was gazing at her back.

Jason continued. "In any case, we're going to be sending a force to that planet along with two of my clones. I plan to create a portal, like I did for Volgarius, so we can begin sending humans there at a rapid rate once it's been established. As for why I called you up front, I'd love it if you and your husband could lead the expedition to the planet. This way, you'll truly have your name carved into the history books."

Jason stared at Amy expectantly, but she felt her stomach flip-flop and her smile fade. "Well, that is very generous, Commander, but I don't think we can accept. We have a daughter and leaving her behind is not an option. We also wouldn't want to bring her along and take her away from her friends."

Jason froze for a moment. "Oh. My apologies, I didn't even think about something like that." He scratched his chin for a moment. "I really do want one of you on the mission though, if possible I'd prefer you go, Amy. You were the one who discovered Revival, so it would be ideal if you received credit for establishing humanity's first outpost outside of our solar system."

Jorge coughed and spoke up. "Err, well, we'll have to talk about this privately. Can we have a few days to think about it?"

Jason nodded as he smiled and extended his hand out to Jorge. "Sure thing! Just let me know what your decision is by the end of June. We're rolling out at the start of July and need to have the protocols ready and crew manifest completed. If you two won't be leading the expedition, I'll have to find an alternate."

"Thank you, sir. We'll see how this goes." Jorge reached out and shook Jason's hand, wincing as the titan of a man nearly crushed his hand.

Amy and her husband quickly walked back and sat down in their seats, Amy still feeling rather lightheaded from the presence of the new Supreme Commander up so close. She hadn't felt this when she met him in her youth, though that may have been because he wore a Hypersuit and she couldn't see his face.

By now, Jorge was beginning to feel more than a little jealous. "Would you quit staring at him?"

Amy blinked twice and then quickly flicked her gaze down. "Sorry, I just can't help it. Something about him is... I don't know."

Amy sighed to herself. Jorge just couldn't understand, as a man, what it was she felt when she looked at the commander. And frankly, neither could she.

Part 334a:

May 4th, 2117.

The Labyrinth. A mysterious place created by the demons, though for what reasons I do not know. In the future I come from, the hallways are a shifting mess of u-turns and double-backs, constantly disorienting the traveler and making it nearly impossible to get to the needed destination.

Here though, with the Crown of Solomon atop my head, it's a cinch. For some reason, the hallways don't shift, at least not this far in the past, during this timeline. The Crown of Solomon gives me information about the layout just like it did in the future, but I've noticed something else that's interesting, thanks in part to the memory boost it also bestows on me... the Labyrinth isn't even a maze, at least not as of now. In fact, the paths are quite straight, leading to many logical areas for living, various huge rooms for training and gestation, and other things of that sort.

It's not maze-like at all, when I can look at it from the perspective of the Crown. I haven't worn the crown for years, mostly because I didn't have too much need for it, but I'm wearing it now. In the future where I started out, the Crown became such a normal part of my body that in effect I grew used to it, and my powers of perception dulled somewhat. It's much like the feeling of having my arm get cut in battle... a sharp, stinging feeling at first, but eventually I lose that sensation and my sense of pain becomes weaker.

By wearing the crown all the time, I become unable to use it to its fullest potential. Best to only use it for important circumstances, like now.

I'm wearing a Hypersuit now, with the Crown atop my helmet. Honestly, it looks kind of stupid, but it works. A small company of 11 clones follows along behind me, all of them wearing black Hypersuits to contrast with my white suit. It makes it more obvious that I'm the leader and the Original, so to speak. Naturally, a huge group of clones are on standby at the JIB just in case we need help fighting demons or whatever.

I only brought along first generation clones, since I wasn't sure what sort of firepower I might need. J1-1, of course, is also coming along. We all call him Sensei as a joke, since he's the oldest living clone, but it sort of morphed into his actual codename.

As we round a corner, heading towards one of the large demon gestation chambers, we walk straight into a hundred skeletons and skeleton commanders, all of them with their weapons at the ready. It seems our path was anticipated.

They start to raise up their weapons to charge at us, but I use my overwhelming telekinetic power to simply smash all of them out of the way, crushing them against a wall, as most of their bones crumble into splinters and litter the ground.

It's been like this the whole way here. I've easily killed a few hundred demons and monsters, with few to stand in my way. My clones have actually had nothing to do, they're really more like groupies that just follow me around.

Still, a surprise ambush by Satan would be undesirable, so I can't afford to get cocky. He's killed me once, though apparently I also came close to returning the favor. That was decades ago, though, and we've both likely taken the lesson to heart. We won't underestimate each other again.

"Original, how much further is it?" Sensei speaks up, a tinge of boredom in his voice, as I expected. The question itself is oddly reminiscent of *are we there yet?*

"The crown says we're about half a mile away from the nearest gestation chamber. We have to go rather slow though, just in case there are surprises."

Sensei nods at me as he seems to infer the meaning of my words without needing specifics. "To be honest, I'd love some action. You're the only one having any fun here."

"I hardly consider this fun." I retort with a smirk on my face that he can't see. This is a lot like playing a video game with all the cheats on and steamrolling everything with no effort. There's simply no challenge in it, and I don't take pleasure in utterly crushing those weaker than me. It's just business, at this point. The only joy I get in crushing the demons is the knowledge that every one of them I kill won't be able to harm a human.

As we walk forwards, my telepathy senses something that makes my skin crawl. Up to now, I hadn't been projecting it forwards much since there are simply too many demons in the labyrinth and all that sensory information could slow down my reflexes, but the gestation chamber is likely to be a key battle point when we arrive, and I need to know what I'm dealing with.

Something is wrong though. This isn't a gestation chamber. It's... something else. I can sense dozens of minds, and all of them are thinking the same thing.

Kill me. Kill me. Kill me.

Over and over again, all of them are simply thinking the same exact thing, a chorus of voices singing a dreadful tune that I no longer wish to hear. I quickly turn my mind away from them.

"Jesus Christ." One of my other clones apparently senses their thoughts too. "Are you leading us the right way? These minds belong to... to..."

"Humans." Sensei speaks up, his voice now sounding on edge.

Up ahead, a light is shining from yet another corner, the hallway itself appearing to widen dramatically. I check my mental map quickly, and it still shows we're approaching a gestation chamber, but that is clearly not what awaits us.

We round the corner, sucking in breaths as a strange sight awaits us. It's a prison of sorts, and humans are all over inside, locked in small, cramped cages, much like mutts at a local shelter. Furthermore, the walls have old, dried blood spattered around in various places. The entire area must be the size of a 5 story hotel, but it's totally hollowed out, with only a series of catwalks going across the upper areas... almost as if they were for observation or something.

"We've been expecting you." A voice speaks up as a confident looking red-skinned demon walks up to us, not a hint of fear on his face. "Expecting one of our spawning chambers, were you? I think you will be quite disappointed."

He's a gentle looking demon, as much of a misnomer as that might be. Frail little arms hidden inside a casual dress shirt and pants that belong to the bottom half of a suit. Coupled with his blood red hair, he looks like a more casual version of Beelzebub, one of the demons I knew from the future. Man, I haven't thought about Beelzy in ages. This guy looks so much like him.

"Who are you? You understand the position you're in, right?" My suit's speakers play my voice out as I speak and he shrugs.

"I'm, err, 'Jake'. Yeah, I'm Jake. That will do. You're too late, since we swapped our testing complex with the hatchery earlier today." Jake glances behind himself before turning back to me, a grimace on his face. "Sorry about the mess on the walls. Sometimes humans resist our orders and we have to give them a little coercion."

Jake winks at me as he says that disgusting thing. I've had about enough of his cocky attitude. These people need my help. I send Jake flying to the side with my telekinesis, his body exploding into pieces, given how hard he hits the wall. I sigh, as I aim my mind at the cages in front of us. Using telekinesis, I unlock all of them at once, before Sensei suddenly speaks up.

"He's not dead."

Huh?

Glancing back at the mess I made, I swallow as I see the pieces of Jake's body quivering slightly. Suddenly, they begin moving towards each other at alarming speeds, and a bright flash of light shines forth, Jake is restored to perfect condition within just a few seconds. His shirt and pants are tattered and in pieces, but his thin, scraggly body is in perfect condition.

"That was rude. Talk about shooting first and asking questions later." Jake rolls his eyes at me. "I'm a unique-class demon. My only power is immortality, the highest kind. I can reform myself after death, even if I'm spattered into tiny droplets of blood. I also don't feel pain. Beyond that, I don't have any other powers, so I'm no threat to you."

He's a mouthy little cunt. "Thanks for the information. I already guessed you weren't a threat. So why are you all alone?"

Jake beckons around the room at all the humans that are climbing out of their cages. "I'm the only demon here. Satan wanted me to speak with you personally. Said something about you and him having an... understanding."

I stare evenly at the demon with the odd ability. He looks even more unimposing, now that his thin arms are visible. "An understanding, huh? The only thing I understand is that demons need to be eradicated. That is the only way to prevent the future I come from." I tilted my head towards the human prisoners, several of whom were looking at our hypersuits with hope in their eyes. "This is barbaric."

"Heh, you think this is barbaric? You've seen nothing. Humans have done worse to the demons, and far worse to other humans. You're the scariest, most evil of all the four sentient races. You may think of demons as evil, but all we wish is for self preservation. If it weren't for the fact that a single human commander, such as yourself, might order our extermination, peace would be possible between our races."

"Peace is overrated. Sooner or later, someone is going to break a treaty. For example, the demons might continue to crowd this labyrinth and require more space than it currently provides. With that in mind, using their superior numbers, they could attack and wipe out us humans. I can't let that happen." I point my finger at him, my eyes narrowing and my voice deepening meaningfully. "I refuse to allow the future I am from come to pass. If demons rule the universe, and the angels are exterminated, you'll treat humans as cattle."

"Cheh. I sincerely doubt that." Jake's smile vanishes as he stares at me with a look of contempt. "As I have spoken with Satan on several occasions, I can assure you that if a situation like that were to occur, we'd simply kill all the humans. We have no need for cattle. I don't know what future you're from, but I'm sure you're remembering it incorrectly."

"Are you calling me a liar?" I grit my teeth as I stare at the little shitbag in front of me. "You don't even know what kind of future I come from. You demons are vile, despicable creatures. I've only ever known a handful that weren't total monsters."

"Yeah, I don't know what future you come from. Feel free to enlighten me. In the meantime, you probably haven't looked very hard. Demons, humans, and angels are all capable of great

horrors, as well as great compassion. You simply see what you wish to see." Jake and I stare at each other nastily, though he can't see my expression inside my helmet. Not that it matters, I'm sure my voice tone is adequate enough to convey my rage.

"I'm not going to explain anything about the future to you. The last thing I want to do is take a chance and give you monsters any ideas, just in case I *do* screw up and fail to eliminate your kind. I won't allow that future to happen because of my own failure."

Jake's face seemed to calm down for a moment, and a split second later, he was smiling again. "That's the thing, isn't it? You really are just guessing, after all. You don't know what you're doing, or if you'll be the one to cause these atrocities to happen, or if you'll prevent them. You're like an infant that accidentally grabbed hold of a gun. It's only a matter of time before you shoot yourself in the foot."

This... this little smug asshole. He seems to think he knows it all, eh? I feel a calm wash over me as I raise my hand and aim my palm at him. "You're a real know-it-all, aren't you? You've got it all figured out. Hell, you probably aren't scared of me due to your inability to feel pain or the fact you can't die. The problem is, both of those things are false, when dealing with me."

Jake's smile fades slightly as he cocks an eyebrow and stares at my hand. "What's this? Some imitation of a stop sign? Maybe you're going to shoot me with some death laser? It's pointless. There's nothing you can do to st-"

I interrupt him as my speakers turn off. He never even hears me say anything. " **Pain... Atomize.** "

I pause for a moment after saying the first word, giving him a split second to feel it before his body evaporates a moment later, his mouth opening in a silent scream of agony as he evaporates into the ether.

I pause for a few moments, then speak again. " **Erase. Forget.** "

Just like that, I've completely eradicated all traces of his body, even at the subatomic and quark levels. By erasing all memories of him from the living in the universe, I've effectively destroyed his existence and all he ever stood for.

Maybe if he hadn't ran his stupid mouth, he'd still be here.

I turn around and notice Sensei is taking his helmet off. "Err, I suddenly feel lightheaded. I feel like I saw something important, but now I can't remember anything."

Hmm. Seems I also erased his memories from my clones as well. I'll have to keep that in mind for the future. "Don't worry about it, we had a pest and he had a troublesome ability. He must have messed with your minds. I managed to stop him."

"Right." Sensei shrugs and rubs his forehead for a moment before putting his helmet back on.

"Teleport these people out of here, then plant the nuke. We'll detonate it once we're clear."

"Roger that."

I sigh as I turn back to the people now rushing frantically towards myself and my clones. Something always has to happen to ruin my plans.

Still though, I wonder why the demons were keeping human prisoners? What reasons could they possibly have? I should have asked Jake before I obliterated him from reality. Curse my idiocy sometimes.

Satan blinked slowly, as a weird muddled feeling appeared in his mind. He staggered back a few steps, wiping at his face as the feeling disappeared.

" Your evilness, something has shifted. I felt the fabric of the universe alter itself for a moment. " A voice spoke from within himself, as Satan glanced down at his chest. Hades, one of the dark gods of the ancient times, and one that Satan had gone out of his way to imprison, rather than kill.

"You're not one to usually speak up first. This must be of some significance." Satan narrowed his eyes as he thought back to the feeling from a few moments earlier. Quickly waving his hands and murmuring quietly, he teleported into the nearby surveillance room, which had been following Jason's movements since he and his clones arrived in the maze. "Has anything happened?"

Marie was sitting in a chair, watching a screen with boredom in her eyes. "Well, for a moment, I had this thought that something did happen, but I can't quite place it. According to the video logs, literally nothing has happened. He did reach the replacement room though, and he just stood completely still for a few minutes, like he was talking to someone. Nobody was there though."

Satan nodded slowly as his eyes shifted up to the screen. Jason's clones were aiming their hands at each prisoner, and a moment later the prisoner would disappear. "I see he's taken the bait. Still, go back to that moment when he arrived. I want to see it."

Marie sighed as she leaned forwards, taking her feet off the console and cycling back through it. A few minutes of rewind footage later, and Satan was left to stare intently at a totally motionless Jason Hiro as he and his clones simply stared ahead, while the prisoners were released and huddled in the distance, as if they were trying to stay away from something frightening.

"How odd. You're right. It looks like he's standing there, speaking with someone but- wait." Satan felt his heart stop for a moment. On the screen, a massive impact smashed into the wall, as if something had been flung into it. But... nothing was there...

Marie also caught it this time, as she blinked and looked at it carefully. "What was that? Did he just attack the wall?"

"Unlikely. This footage is very good quality too, and I didn't see any object hit. What could the meaning to that impact be?" Satan gnawed on his lip intently.

Hades rumbled from within him. " **My liege, as I said, something shifted. I do not know what, but we have already seen the latent potential that hero possesses. He may have altered something fundamental to the universe. Such power would usually be unthinkable, but...**"

Hades trailed off, and Satan glared at the screen viciously. "Wouldn't it be interesting if this recording had somehow been tampered with?"

Marie started to object, but instead shrugged. "I'd normally say it's a practically impossible feat, but given what we've seen Jason do before, it's not outside the realm of possibility. To hack these recordings and edit them so well in the span of a few minutes, without ever leaving the place he's at now... it would be..."

She was about to elaborate, but suddenly her screen flickered, as did all of the electric based technology in the room. A moment later, the entire place shook violently, as a huge shockwave blasted out from all areas of the labyrinth at once. A colossal 'WHUMP' could be heard, as if smashing a million hammers into a concrete barrier a mile away. Several demons as well as Marie screamed in fright. All of the people in the room stumbled to the ground and fell flat on their backs as they blinked in confusion.

Just as quickly as it came, it was gone. "What the hell was that?!" Marie screamed in anger as she reached up and clawed at the desk she had been sitting at, realizing she had hit her head on the way down. The lights were out, as were all of the other electronics. Only a few dim backup lights, powered by magical systems, were running properly.

Satan stood up gracefully in the blink of an eye, quickly surveying the damage. Everyone appeared to be fine. "You heard the female. I want a report!"

One of the sensory-type demons focused for a moment as he spoke with others of his kind, scattered all over the labyrinth. "There was a massive explosion, coming from the area where those commandos were located. Based on the sheer power, it must have been a nuclear device."

Marie nodded quickly. "That wasn't an ordinary nuke. It must have been a two-stage explosion, first to cause damage, then followed up by an EMP effect. Probably, it was one of those new ones that I heard was being worked on by the human scientists in London. Top secret stuff. I didn't think they were ready yet though, and the power needed would be..."

Satan scowled. "That hero is a thorn in my side. I want a casualty report, as well as a report on the damage the labyrinth sustained. Luckily, that installation wasn't close to anything too important, but..."

"Neither were we, and we felt it." Marie glanced at him and nodded knowingly. "That must have been a tremendous blast radius. I can only guess it was enhanced somehow, perhaps with his magical abilities."

Satan gnashed his teeth as he pounded her desk. "Damn him to hell! He outwitted me again!"

Marie shook her head quickly. "No, calm down. That is not the case. This labyrinth is massive. Even if the blast was several megatons in size, we can rebuild. It's all created by magical power anyway. Besides that, Jason took the assets we left him. I'm sure they will serve their purpose in the near future."

Satan's breathing slowed as he quickly regained control of his emotions. "Right. You have a point, as usual. I'm not fond of the idea of my brethren dying, but sacrifices are necessary in a battle to win a war. I do apologize for my outburst."

As he calmed himself down, Marie stood up and meandered over to the other side of the room. "I'm going to personally go and inspect the damage. Care to tag along? I'd hate to encounter Jason all by myself."

Satan nodded. "Yes, that will do. I got the impression this was a hit and run operation, but it can't hurt to be sure. Let's go."

The two of them walked quickly out the door a few moments later.

Still, Satan thought back to the image of that wall being smashed. *What had gone on during those few minutes that he couldn't recall now?*

Part 335a: Alterations

Clarence sat quietly on the bench in his private dressing room as the dull roar of the anxious crowd outside awaited him. Just fifteen more minutes, and it would be time for him to make yet another raucous speech.

He tapped his finger on his knee slowly, as he felt an odd muddled sensation in his mind. The words in his mind seemed to form themselves more slowly than usual, as he debated over what to preach about today. He could probably just autopilot it again, as he had been doing for a long time now. It's not like the idiots would notice anyway.

His finger's motion slowed to a crawl as a familiar shifting of wind made him pause and take notice of a visitor. "Raphael. I see you've come to say hello."

"You've become more perceptive over the years." Raphael smiled kindly as he ambled over, leaning heavily on his staff as he tended to do. "Something on your mind? You seem less energetic these days."

"Oh... you know how it is." Clarence shrugged slightly as he glanced up at the Archangel drawing closer, a strange feeling making him break eye contact after less than a second. "I'm just getting... old. I can't think as clearly as I did even just a few years ago."

"Hmm. Interesting." Raphael kept his voice neutral as he came to a standstill a few feet away, eyeing the human carefully. "You seem to say that a lot lately. Are you certain there's nothing else?"

Clarence chewed on his lip in silence for a moment as he stared at the ground in front of himself. "Well, to tell the truth, I've been thinking about myself a lot."

Raphael waited patiently for a few moments but Clarence didn't elaborate. "Yes, and?"

"I am... a shallow being. All I live for is money. I've been thinking about that for a long time now... money seems so empty, so vacuous. I don't even know why I pursue it."

Raphael nodded very slowly as he narrowed his eyes. "I... see. You're beginning to regret spending all your time and effort getting money, then, is that it?"

"Something like that." Clarence reached up and scratched his chin as he felt unease regarding Raphael's steady gaze. "It's more that I have this platform to really make a difference in our world, and I'm not using it well. Why do the lower proletariat classes still worry about money? We have replicators now, things that can create any object desired using just a bit of fusion energy, which should be unlimited... yet we still worry about money and other such

things, perhaps as signs of status. It seems so wasteful. We should move into a more utopian future, even despite the war with the demons."

Raphael cocked an eyebrow and shrugged. "Who can know? Personally, I speak for the angels when I say the war benefits us. It benefits you as well, Clarence. For your work here on Earth, you understand you will be given a prominent position among the angels when you die, correct? You will live forever among us as one who is only slightly below the gods and archangels themselves. You also have the option of using the nanobots, if you should so choose to prolong the pleasures to be found here on Earth. We truly care not what you choose to do, so long as you advance our will."

"I understand." Clarence quickly looked up at the old angel, forcing a smile. "Truly, you have blessed me. I have so many followers now who appreciate my words and wish to hear me speak... I don't know what I would do without you."

Raphael felt his own insincere smile squeeze through as the sides of his mouth curled up slightly. "It is entirely because of your own ability and nothing else. The people simply love you for what you preach. Just keep preaching it, and all will be well."

Clarence glanced down at his old fashioned watch, standing up quickly as he realized it was time again. "Alright, I'm off now. Wish me luck."

"You, of all people, have no need for such a thing as luck." Raphael's smile faded slightly as he turned and walked away from the dark skinned human.

Truly, this human would become a thorn in his side sooner rather than later.

Clarence sighed slowly, pulling himself up from the bench with great deliberation, as he walked forwards to the door that would lead him to his faithful followers.

Amy and Sarah stared excitedly up at the platform, both of them feeling quite heated thanks to the ambient temperature in the room. With two hundred thousand other people all packed into the massive stadium, in the bleachers as well as on the floor, it had to be fifteen degrees hotter than the outside world. The air conditioners in the stadium, as advanced as they were, just couldn't keep the room cool enough to mitigate the heat produced by all these walking ninety-eight degree radiators babbling at each other.

Sarah, particularly, seemed very excited by this preacher. "He's so handsome! He might be fifty, but he looks thirty! And he has all of that energy too!"

Amy agreed with her daughter about his good looks, but... it was something about his message. It just appealed to her on a primal level. "Let's not forget about what he's saying. Peace is important, Sarah. We need to make peace with the angels, and keep fighting the demons."

"Yes, I know that much!" Sarah started to say something else but paused as the crowd once again quieted down, almost by instinct. Apparently, it was time.

A few seconds passed, and finally the curtain opened up as Clarence walked onto the stage. Amy squinted, noticing he seemed to be less exuberant than usual. He wasn't smiling like he usually did, and instead seemed to be faking his happiness. "My children! I am pleased to see you all." His voice was more muted than usual, and it seemed to have a strange edge to it.

Still, the crowd roared with delight at his words. Sarah didn't seem to notice his behavior was any different from normal, but Amy felt unnerved.

"Today is an important day! This marks the twenty-fifth anniversary from when I started my journey to rebuild my life! Two and a half decades ago, I was a broken, hollow man. I owned nothing, and lived in squalor. I did drugs, and smoked, and committed many relatively minor sins, but all of that changed one day, shortly after my twenty seventh birthday. I was in a parking lot, staring at a man and his wife, as well as their two children. I was moved by how well dressed they were and by how happy they seemed. I began to pay attention to them, since they seemed to frequent the place I was living at on a regular basis to obtain various goods."

"The man's name was Samuel, and I found this out when I approached him one day and decided to finally gather up my courage and speak with him. As it turned out, he was a man of the cloth, one who still believed in the old ways of following the bible. Precious few people seemed to think as he did, and he lived in relative stability with his family, the last percent of Earth who still believed in the power of God to transform their lives into something more meaningful... something that held more value than a mere mortal existence. Samuel believed that he was here for a purpose, and that purpose was to fulfill God's will by living a clean, wholesome life."

Clarence paused for a second, his unusually soft voice cracking as some emotion seemed to overtake him for a moment. He continued after taking a breath to compose himself. "This revelation changed me. It's cliched, I know... but Samuel showed me the light, allowing me to improve my life and gain the respect of so many today."

The crowd started to cheer, but Clarence hushed them as he held his palm up. "No... no, save your praise. I have thought long and hard, and I have realized... even now, I am still a sinner. I improved my life and became a better person in many ways, it is true, but in the end, old habits die hard. I have preached for the love of money, not for the love of purity. I must admit now to my entire flock that... I am still very much a sinner. I love money, and I love women, and I love booze... and in truth, until recently, I viewed all of the people in this room as my inferiors."

The room fell completely silent as the crowd stared up at their beloved preached in stunned silence. Even Amy and Sarah failed to come up with a mental response to his words.

"I have sinned. Badly." Clarence's shoulder slumped, as he stared around the room with a muted gaze. "It is because of this sin that I must now speak up and heal those who have unwittingly suffered because of my actions. So many of you donate to the church, but you do not realize... every penny goes into my pockets. Very little is related to 'administrative costs'. We are not oppressed by the government, nor have we ever been. Everything about me is a sham. I am... a fraud."

Clarence's voice caught again as he stared out at the faces of his flock. Their expressions told the story he knew they would... disappointment. Sadness. Betrayal.

He started to speak again, but the crowd suddenly roused themselves, as a familiar presence was felt behind himself.

"Clarence. What do you think you're doing?" The archangel Raphael stood behind him, his cane nowhere in sight, as his wings were spread out in all their full glory. He must have appeared via teleportation directly to the stage. His voice was barely a whisper, only Clarence could hear what he had said.

Clarence narrowed his eyes to a slit. Was this perhaps... fear? Did the archangel fear the power this mere human held?

"Something I should have done a long time ago, Raphael. You have used me for too long. I understand now, what a danger you present to humanity. You are not our savior, but our instrument of destruction!" Clarence spoke into the mic as he swiveled around and pointed directly at Raphael.

"You are the true evil on this world! You take the energy of humanity, using us as mere cattle for your own selfish ambitions! In front of all my followers, both on the stage and broadcasting to the world before us now, I say to you, Archangel Raphael... *you* are the devil, not Satan!"

Clarence had hardly finished speaking when Raphael's eyes were filled with a terrible rage, something silent one might only see by gazing directly into them. "Fool. You have made a grave mistake, angering the gods." In the blink of an eye, Raphael pulled a sword out from behind himself, lunging forwards with an uncanny speed, as he impaled Clarence straight into the center of his heart.

Clarence gasped, his vision becoming unsteady, as Raphael yanked it back out with the quickest of movement, a look of loathing on his face. "A pity. You had such potential."

The preacher took a step backwards, as blood gushed from the wound. A second later, his vision faded to black, as he fell deep into an abyss far beyond his comprehension.

As he fell to the ground, the stadium was filled with fear and confusion. Amy and Sarah gawked in horror at how the man they had begun watching only a short while ago lay dead before them, his blood pooling all around his body as his heart gave its last, weak jolt.

The archangel's voice suddenly boomed out from all areas of the stadium, as he raised his hands to the sky. "Children of god, hear me now! I am the Archangel Raphael, known as the wisest of my people! This man, Father Clarence, lived a just and holy life! However, in the end, he was found to be collaborating with the demons, and sought to turn against us, pitting their powers against ours! As you must have guessed by now, I had to kill him before he could complete this plot. Even now, the demons await his signal to attack. With his final act of terrorism averted, we must move forwards, not by forgetting the goodness of his life, but by washing away his sin with this final sacrifice."

As the archangel spoke, that strange feeling entered Amy and Sarah's mind as they both nodded numbly, the two of them not quite understanding what had just transpired. Still, the angel's words *did* make some sense.

Amy knew that the angels absorbed the energy of humans to sustain their own lives, but Clarence had clearly fallen to the side of the demons in the end. The angels might need to be a tad unscrupulous, but the demons were clearly worse. Terrorism and violence was their forte. Yes, indeed, this was the case. Amy knew the archangel wasn't lying. Clarence was bad. He was a secret messenger of evil. He was the enemy.

Raphael continued to speak as the crowd leaned in more intently to listen to his words.

Perfect. Humans give us this fanatical energy, which we in turn use to subtly influence their minds. A perfect cycle of enrichment that will enable our kind to flourish. Zeus's ability to use magic truly knows no bounds.

He smiled, as the crowd began to nod along once more. A new preacher would be required... but perhaps this time, one who would be a little easier to *control*.

I walked along with my clones, gawking at the massive crater left behind by the nuclear device. Far in the distance in all directions, hallways broken and shattered could be seen, as a huge spherical section of the labyrinth several miles in diameter had been blown. It would ordinarily be quite hard to see, given there was no natural light in the labyrinth, but I had cast 'Light' some time ago and we were walking around as if it were a sunny day in this section.

Sensei and I had taken our helmets off as we walked around. The nuke we had used was a 'clean' nuke, one with little to no radiation. We were in no danger, and with all the enemies

gone, it had been a depressingly easy day of crushing the leftover enemies. Despite the clean sphere left over from the nuke, hundreds of miles of hallways had debris blasted around inside their corridors, making it nearly impossible for anyone to come out and fight us.

As I had those thoughts, a skeleton charged at me. I barely blinked as his sword smashed against my Hypersuit, snapping in half. A second later, I punched backwards, shattering it in a single blow as the undead creature fell to shards behind me.

"Sensei, how powerful would you say we are compared to the demonic threat?"

He pauses as he thoughtfully taps on his lip. In the distance, I hear the sounds of a small scuffle that come to a rapid end as two of my clones kill several orcs in the span of a few seconds. "Tough to say. I don't really even know what the demons are, honestly. There seem to be actual demons, but also monsters like goblins and skeletons and whatnot. Not a single one of the monster variety has posed the slightest challenge to us, but the demons are quite a bit more powerful. I suspect they might be biding their time though, waiting before they attack us. They're still sizing us up."

I nod at his assessment. The first generation clones had fought in many battles that even I hadn't. They had faced off against demons, monsters, and Volgrim on several occasions when I was occupied with other things. He likely knows things that even I don't.

"Satan is extremely powerful, but he might be an outlier. I defeated Bael rather easily. I know that Belial is quite strong... really though, unless they're holding back, Satan seems to be the cream of the crop. I can't see any of them being a real challenge other than him."

Sensei pauses, as if to contemplate something. "It's funny you say that. Satan can't be that tough. Certainly, he's powerful, but we have the ability to bend reality. Beyond that, you have thousands of clones. Considering how he fared against your Hypersuit when you... temporarily passed on... it seems likely that several of us at once would be easily able to defeat him. This would mean..." My clone pauses as he slowly tilts his head up to stare at the distant ceiling of the labyrinth. "...The future has already been changed. We must be in a different timeline. If we were somehow already a part of our original timeline, then Satan and all of the demons would have been easily killed by us. There's simply no way at the rate we're already progressing that the demons can't be exterminated. It's just too easy."

"Let's not get cocky now." I chide him gently, but I'm having the same misgivings. He's right, after all. I keep having these doubts, but there's no question to it. The future is being altered. We're making progress. "Anything could happen."

Sensei smiles, as his eyes rove across the distance. "Funny you say that. We have a visitor. Two, actually."

I follow his gaze and feel my teeth clench involuntarily. Standing silently, staring at the two of us, are Satan and Marie.

Marie... it's been a long time. Well over a hundred years, as a matter of fact.

Considering it's over a mile away, I decide to simply teleport over to them, as does Sensei. We arrive several feet away from them, keeping our distance.

"Look who's here... the titular Hero himself." Marie smiles pleasantly at me, hiding her opinions perfectly. "Hello, Jason. I see you've really had some fun here."

"Marie." I acknowledge her presence with a single word, grinning tightly as I suppress my distrust and unease. "It's been a long time. How did you like the present I left you, the last time we met?"

Marie chuckled. "The cadaver was very clever. You had us bamboozled for years. We only began to understand what had happened after you made your appearance at the WCN. Once we realized that strange suited man was a Candidate, it became apparent it was you. A shame it took us so long, we might have been able to prevent the destruction of the Americas."

"You know damn well it was your fault all those people died. Besides, you're awfully chatty today." I glared at the beautiful redhead, who shrugged innocently.

"I'm just a poor lady who got sucked up in all of this. It's not my fault that you men are always busy swinging your codpieces around, having stupid contests with each other."

Satan grimaces. "Shut up, Marie. Your acting is starting to get on my nerves too." He rolls his eyes as he tilts his head back to look at me. "You're really pissing me off lately, whelp. Killing my demons, blowing up my labyrinth. You don't seem to think twice about killing anymore, do you?"

I shake my head slowly. "Nope. At least, not when it comes to demons and the Volgrim. I stand with humanity now. I'm going to actively oppose the future that I come from. I can't allow it to happen, no matter what."

"Isn't that *cute*." Satan sneers as his eyes flick around to observe the devastation all around us. "No different from what humans always do. Attack those who are 'different' from you. It used to be about their nation, then it was about their skin color, now it's those of a different species. Humans are such... vile pests."

"You and your demons killed over a thousand people at a resort hotel on Earth. Those people were innocents too, Satan. Don't preach at me from a pedestal when you're one who murders innocents." I bite my lip in frustration as I stare evenly at him. "What did you think would

happen next? You can't poke a bear and expect it not to attack. You knew we would counter attack."

"I did." Satan lowers his eyes slightly. "But this was... simply..." For a moment, I almost think I can see a hint of sadness in his eyes, but he flicks them upwards defiantly, as if to spite me. "This was a slaughter. There is no glory, or honor, or sport in using such weapons. Just as when you obliterated Volgarius, you have turned to acts of mass murder."

"Glory? Honor? Coming from the one who murdered hundreds of millions of humans in the American continents..." Sensei speaks up this time, rage in his eyes. "You're a fucking hypocrite."

Marie sighs dramatically. "Now now, boys. Let's calm down a moment. Can't we all just work out our problems? Can't we just talk for a moment? Nobody remembers who started what anymore, but the costs have escalated quite dramatically. Don't we all agree peace is for the best, for all our sakes?"

Satan quickly turns his fiery glare back at her. "Easy for you to say. I have fought for thousands and thousands of years, all for the sake of revenge. Firstly against the angels, and secondly against humanity. I won't give that up so easily for a false peace."

"You sound quite stubborn, then. So long as you fight, I will too." I glare at the hotheaded demon across from me. "If millions, billions, even trillions must die, so be it. I will never allow the demons to prosper. I must eliminate your threat from the universe. You, who speaks from atop a soapbox, as if you have some divine authority to judge my kind. If you won't see the light, neither will I."

Satan chuckles. "I'm not being hypocritical. I never claimed to be the arbiter of moral authority. You, however, did. You once claimed to be a hero, one who fought for justice. Yet you show your true colors now. A godlike figure who seeks to turn all to his own will. I will oppose you, just as I did Kronos, Zeus, and all the other heroes before you."

I stare evenly at the two of them, as they stare back at Sensei and I. This is pointless. So long as he is alive, Satan will never back down. Peace is impossible. Still, though...

"Sensei, you said before that we have already changed the timeline, right?"

I speak to my clone, and he nods at me. "Yeah. That's my working theory, anyway."

"I say it's time for another alteration. This one, for sure, will change the future. It's been a long time coming, too."

Satan and Marie both eye me suspiciously. Marie is the first to respond. "Change the timeline? What are you planning? I think you'll find that we won't go down without a fight so

easily."

I nod soberly as I eye the woman up and down. "You're half right. Satan won't, at the least."

She's unarmored, protected only by a short range anti-magic field. I keep my gaze on her without saying anything. From high in the sky, my telekinesis shifts a chunk of the labyrinth's ceiling loose, as it begins its rapid descent towards the target.

"You're a cunning woman, Marie. I can't use telekinesis, or any sort of simple death word on you. You must have figured out my wordsmithing long ago."

She smirks, her suspicions replaced with a false bravado. Just as she starts to speak, the half-ton chunk of ceiling hits her.

It's brutal. The instant it impacts her, her body explodes into a trillion fragments, her lithe frame crushed into oblivion. Every fabric of her existence is crushed and eliminated from this universe in the blink of an eye. Satan takes a second to even notice it, suddenly jerking his head to the side as he gawks.

"Y-you... killed her? A defenseless... woman?"

"I did."

I stare at him coldly as he turns to look back at me in shock. He doesn't seem horrified by her death, or disgusted that I would do such a thing, but rather...

Awe and fear are apparent in his eyes instead. "You're... different. You're not the same as when we last fought."

"I'm not."

He merely nods at my words. "If we fight here, it will be a long protracted battle, but I will surely lose. This round goes to you, Jason Hiro. I commend you for acting so decisively though." He again glances down at the impact crater the debris left behind, blood from Marie's crushed corpse splattered all over the two of us. "She was a pest. Useful, but a pest nonetheless. With her gone, I will begin fighting you in earnest."

I want to tell him that he wasn't allowed to leave and that we were going to end this here, but something told me not to bother. He was a threat, but only a minor one now. We would have another chance soon.

"Take care of yourself, Satan. Don't disappoint me. From one genocidal maniac to another, may the best ruler win."

"Indeed, I will." Satan smiles, as he vanishes an instant later.

I glance down at the bloody mess across from me. With Marie gone, the future will change. How it will change, I do not know, but change it will.

"Sometimes, I wonder about you." Sensei speaks softly, as he averts his gaze from me.

He doesn't understand. Nobody does.

Part 336a:

Satan paused as he stood before the door that led back to the intelligence room. He contemplated the acts of Jason Hiro silently in his mind, replaying the scene over and over again. *That strange confidence he had, the flippant disregard for life. When did such things become part of the Heroic Code?*

Still though, his powers were incredible. If they hadn't been interrupted all those years ago, Satan would have absorbed the powers of Wordsmithing for sure. If he had done that, then... Jason would no longer be a threat. Hell, when he thought about it, Satan had to stifle a mighty laugh from the pit of his belly. Jason would only have his Wordsmithing, while Satan would have all the abilities of foes he had devoured over the millennia, plus the powers of Wordsmithing. It wouldn't even be a battle anymore. All the cosmic powers of the universe would be laid bare for him to control.

Satan smirked to himself as he opened the door to the surveillance room.

The door swung open and Satan froze in place, confusion blasting from every pore on his body.

Marie Becker walked around, tapping on her datapad as she normally would do, and was chatting with a demon casually.

"M-... Marie?" Satan's jaw slackened slightly as he stared in disbelief at the woman walking around. It was as if he were looking at a ghost.

She paused and glanced up, poking her glasses back on her nose. "Mmm. You're back. Took you long enough. Did you casually stroll the three hundred or so miles, or did you run? Either way, you sure as hell didn't make use of those useful teleportation abilities."

"You're... alive? How?" Satan ignored her snide comments for once, completely bamboozled by her appearance, standing there in the flesh.

"What are you saying? I'm dead, imbecile. All thanks to you. I already knew not to trust you very much, but then you just let the bastard kill me. It's hard to even call you a tentative ally at this point. The others are stretched thin as it is, but you had to make things worse."

Satan nodded slowly as he walked forwards, eying her up and down. "Others? I don't follow. It's rare for me to be surprised by anything, let alone at the magnitude that I am now. Are you some sort of clone? I knew you were a shrewd woman, but to have a backup body..." Satan

paused, as a sudden realization appeared in his eye. "Ah, I understand now. You're a hero after all, aren't you? This must be your heroic ability."

Marie immediately rolled her eyes and sighed dramatically. "Gods, you're thick sometimes. I'm neither a hero, nor a clone, nor the original. That's three strikes. If you were any dumber, I'd be totally depressed. Let's just say that I am everywhere, and nowhere at once, shall we?"

Satan narrowed his eyes as he glared at her intently. "None of those? What the hell could it be, then? Are you even a human? Perhaps some sort of humanoid robot? I can't wrap my mind around-"

Marie held up her palm and aimed it at his face. "You're giving me a headache. I'll explain if you just stop blabbering, all right? It's simple. I'm from another universe."

Satan blinked as he waited for elaboration, but she didn't continue. "Is that it?"

"Huh? What more do you want from me? Christ." Marie stormed over to a chair and plopped down in it, staring at him with a deeply annoyed expression spread across her face. "All right, listen carefully because I'm only going to say it once."

She continued. "There are an infinite number of universes, or so the theory goes. Each universe is split off from ours by the choices we make. In actuality, there are a finite number of universes, each branching off from a 'main' universe. This universe has several thousand other ones that branch off from it, and I exist in many of them. As time goes on, universes that diverge too greatly from ours become inaccessible, meaning they are impossible to reach. I alone, with my incredible genius, merely figured out how to travel between them."

She smiled smugly, content with her explanation, as Satan was left grasping for further clues. "Doesn't that make you immortal, then, if you can just replace yourself when you die?"

"Of course not. Because my copy died in this universe, several thousand of the other ones also died in similar brutal events. I come from a universe that is almost exactly identical to this one, except in that one, you didn't let me die. You're more of a gentleman there, but just as stupid as you are here."

Satan groaned at her constant barrage of insults, but then merely rapped on his chin as he thought about what she said. "That is certainly a handy method of preserving your life. I will give you immortality in this universe if you tell me how I might use it to preserve my own life, should the worst happen."

Marie stared at him quietly for a few moments before suddenly jumping up from her chair and bursting into laughter. "Hahaha!! You believed me?! What a moron! I knew you were stupid but this is beyond anything I ever imagined!"

Satan glowered at her as he fought down a snarl. "You're... mocking me again? If you aren't a traveler from another universe, then what the hell are you?! Out with it!"

Marie immediately stopped laughing and stared at him with a blank expression. "I'm a clone."

"Ah." Satan felt taken aback by her sudden mood shift. "I cannot tell if you are toying with me again or not."

"Maybe. I might have just instantly replaced my body with a fake and teleported away, too. Hard to say."

"Are you being serious?"

"That is a tough question to answer."

Marie stared at him with a completely blank expression as Satan stared back. "Whatever. I don't care. You're back, you're annoying again, you're still the same pest as you ever were."

"I could say the same thing. At least I got a laugh out of this. I love playing around with the minds of inferior beings, even if that does include all who've ever lived." Marie's smile returned, as her mouth turned up at the corners ever so slightly.

"Does that include those who could kill you with the barest effort if they so desired?"

"Yes, and they above all others provide me with the thrill I seek to keep on living life to the fullest!" Marie paused as a coquettish look passed over her eyes. "Besides, Satan dearest, you are not one of those beings. Never forget that."

"We shall see." Satan turned his back on her as he took a deep breath and released the rage he had been feeling in a single smooth motion. "I'll be back. I'm going to speak with Belial about... things. Keep me updated on any new developments."

"We shall see." Marie echoed his comment back at him as the door slammed shut.

A few moments passed, as Marie turned to the datapad in her hand, one of the Others appearing onscreen. "Is he gone?"

"Yes. A rude interrupter, as always." Marie admired the beautiful face of the familiar looking redhead who stared back at her. *Damn, I'm sexy.* "Our stability, what is it sitting at?"

"We can't suffer even a single loss anymore. Marie 12b was a key figure in holding this stream together. We're on our last life."

Marie grimaced as she looked away from the pad. "Cat's out of the bag, and she wasted eight of her lives. I can't believe 12b didn't see such an obvious attack coming. The Jasons from this

stream are much more aggressive than the ones from the outliers. I guess what they say about hindsight is true."

"We'll just have to be even more careful from now on."

"Agreed."

I stroll into the London HQ, arriving to the sight of several people turning and saluting, their eyes staring expectantly at me. I say nothing for a few moments, trying hard to force a sad expression across my face, but finally I relent and a huge smile spreads across my face almost involuntarily. "It was a huge success!"

The room erupts in cheers and whooping laughter as people crowd around in front of me.

"Supreme Commander, did you manage to kill the leader as well?!"

"Commander, how did you find out about the hostages?!"

"Commander Jason! We're so glad to have you back!"

Questions and compliments fly at me from all directions, but I quickly wave them off. "It was no problem, thanks to my clones and the Hypersuits. Success was assured from the very start. Their leader still lives, but we've dealt the first of many blows that will prove to be fatal to the demons!"

The people in the room clap enthusiastically as they start murmuring and chattering to each other about my escapades, and I felt a calm feeling wash over me... the knowledge of a job well done. Marie is dead, millions of demons were eradicated, Satan had finally learned that I meant business... and I am now content in the knowledge that aside from Satan, no demon is a match for me, let alone my army of clones.

Life seems pretty good right about now.

A woman pushes through the throng of onlookers, tilting her head way back to look up at me. She's quite the shorty. "You have a couple visitors in the office, Commander Hiro. Non-urgent, but they have been waiting for about an hour."

"Oh, thanks, Rebecca." She's one of the assistants who was assigned to me. She hands me my security clearance card, something I always leave behind at the office, just in case. I can teleport anywhere in the building anyway, so it's just a formality.

Pushing past the crowd of excited onlookers, I make my way into the office and am greeted by the sight of two familiar people.

"Mr. and Mrs. Gutierrez. A pleasure to see the both of you again." I walk forwards and shake their hands after they both jump up to greet me. "Sorry to keep the both of you waiting."

Amy's face reddens and she looks away from me, but Jorge keeps his cool. His wife is probably just unsure of how to act in front of a Supreme Commander. Having a big fancy title is such a pain sometimes...

"Commander Jason, we've been thinking about your offer and we'd love to talk with you about it." Jorge nods as a big grin fills his face.

"Glad to hear it. Let's all have a seat and discuss it over coffee." I send a telepathic message to Rebecca, who quickly gets up from her seat out in the secretary wing and runs to get us coffee. Unlike others I've spoken to, she doesn't seem particularly disquieted by my use of telepathy. It's a nice change of pace, for once.

I sit down across the desk, marveling at its craftsmanship yet again. This is the same exact desk that I once sat at, directly across from Stonewall, as he told me to piss off and stop helping Earth. Seems that didn't work out so well for him.

"Alright, so what's all this about?" I smile with what I hope is a pleasant expression, as I kick back in my chair and sigh heavily.

Amy speaks up this time. "It's about the trip back to planet Revival. We talked it over a lot recently, and given some... recent events, we've come to make a decision regarding the trip."

"I will go to Revival." Jorge speaks up, but his bravado vanishes in an instant as hesitation takes its place.

"Oh? Just you? I assumed either the both of you would go, or neither. Why you, specifically?" I lean forwards and stare at him, noticing he seems rather disconcerted.

"Well, the logic was that Amy had already seen the planet, while I had not. It's a 7 year trip there, but once the portal is established, the return trip is instant. I didn't want to pull our daughter out of school, and neither did Amy, so..."

I cock an eyebrow. "Neither of you has to go, you know. It wasn't an order. Hell, if you want, you can both stay behind and just wait for the crew to arrive, then we open up the portal and you travel there. It's the same situation, except this way you can stay with your daughter."

Amy shoots a glance at Jorge, and he returns the look before turning back to me. "That wouldn't be fair to the men and women who have to suffer through a seven year trip. We shouldn't get the privilege of being a part of history while not having to make any sacrifices. Besides, I hear your clones will be able to allow the crew to communicate with the home teams instantly? I'm not going to miss a moment of my daughter growing up."

I grin at him. "Right you are! And if you ever need to return home, or any of the crew does, that can be arranged without even slowing down the trip."

His body finally loosened up a bit as some of the tension he had apparently been feeling evaporated.

Sensing a short break in the conversation, Amy spoke up. "Say, Commander Hiro, I know you were gone for over two days... so you probably didn't hear. Father Clarence, the man who preaches for the Church of Retribution... he was murdered today. On the stage while preaching, actually." Her expression hardened slightly as a look of disgust flooded her face. "I... I witnessed it, live."

I nodded slowly, as I stared at her. "I'm sorry you had to see that. It sounds terrible. I'm also sorry for not being emotional or anything, but I don't know anything about the man. I'm not really into the whole 'church' thing."

Amy swallowed carefully. "Right. It's, ah, not really about him so much... it's the person who killed him. The Archangel Raphael... impaled him with a sword. I thought you might want to know, since you seem to be on friendly terms with them."

I jerked my body back into an upright position, my pleasant expression vanishing in an instant. "Say what? Raphael?! Impossible. He's simply not the type to do that."

"I saw it with my own two eyes. It was quite brutal. To be fair, Clarence was preaching heresy like a madman but... I thought the archangel might have gone too far."

"Cheh. No kidding." I felt my gaze drift away as I thought of what crazy scenario would lead to him doing such a thing. He's... not the type... is he? Sheesh, I've spoken with the angels for decades, an entire century if not longer. For him to act that brash... what the hell sort of reason might he have?

"I'll speak with him. Thank you for telling me." I nod at her as I force a smile. She doesn't return the look, as her face is clouded with numbness. I barely tap into her mind and get a vivid picture of the execution as it happened. I could dig deeper with my telepathy if I so chose, but I decide not to.

The three of us sit in silence for a few moments, before Jorge finally coughs awkwardly and stands up, tapping his wife's shoulder as she rises too. "Well, we will be heading out then. Thank you for having us, Supreme Commander."

As he reaches across the desk, I lean forwards at the same time and shake his hand firmly. "Call me Jason. I hate that formal crap, honestly."

Jorge chuckled. "Don't we all? But protocol is important. Let order slip, and you'll have mutiny within a few months! Have a pleasant day, Commander."

Amy blushes again as that same sweet smile appears. "Yes, have a pleasant day... Jason." As she and her husband turn to walk away, I stare at her long flowing blonde hair. From the rear, she almost seems familiar.

It's probably nothing. I glance upwards vacantly at the ceiling, trying to see past it up to the heavens themselves.

Those fucking gods and archangels. What is the meaning of this? Why now?

" **Teleport.** "

Part 337a: Moles

"Uhhhh.... hahhhh... what?" Clarence drearily blinked his eyes open, as he looked around at the absolute pitch blackness surrounding him. No, wait, that wasn't correct. In fact, it wasn't pitch blackness, but a blinding whiteness, surrounding him from all directions, like the brightness of ten thousand spotlights all at once. It made his brain scream in agony.

He closed his eyes for a few moments and rubbed them, suddenly realizing he was somehow standing up. Standing? That didn't make any sense. Hadn't he just been stabbed a few moments before? Or was that an eternity ago? Where was the pain?

Questions began to arise as he opened his eyes again, squinting carefully to try and get his bearings.

Grass. There was a strange grass all around him, a sort of blueish hue that didn't quite look like the kind he had seen on Earth. He smiled involuntarily. *Bluegrass. Heh.*

The smile passed a moment later, as he realized there was movement. From every direction, his mind began to discern the impression of sound. It was as if he had exited a vacuum and all of his senses were turning on slowly, one by one, similar to a computer turning on its components piece by piece.

He sniffed the air, but no fragrance was noticeable. Familiar looking, yet alien figures moved and milled about. Hundreds of them. Thousands. No... *millions*. As far as he could see, in tightly packed clusters here and there, they chattered at one another, their voices forming an unbearable cacophony of distracting noise. Clarence covered his ears, wincing as the noise was barely muted.

After a minute or so, the noise became less unbearable as he seemed to adjust to it. He had begun to realize what was going on... and what had happened to him. There could be no doubt, these were angels moving about. The wings made that part especially obvious. If there were millions of angels all around him, then that could only mean...

"This is Heaven?" He stared around, dumbfounded, as the question left his lips almost involuntarily.

"Duh." A woman sat nearby, her dark red hair spilling down her white robes and all around her back and chest. She seemed unthinkably bored. "You're a real master of the obvious."

Clarence tilted his head over to look at her, catching a glimpse of his own wings as he jerked his head back in awe to stare at them. He quickly regained his composure as he fully turned to

face the woman sitting on the grass. "You're sitting down on the ground? Even with all these, err, angels around? Aren't you worried you'll get trampled?"

The woman chuckled. "That's cute. You're a funny guy. At this point, I don't think it would hurt... being stepped on, I mean." Her face crinkled into an odd expression as she slowly gazed away. "What a pity I had to end up here. You, however, seem totally dumbfounded."

Clarence shrugged nonchalantly as he looked back and forth. "Truth be told, I had always hoped I'd end up in heaven, at least for the last few years... I mean, considering I dedicated my life to the service of God, it seemed obvious. It's just... the manner in which I died was..."

She flippantly waved her hand at him. "Oh *please*. You don't know the half of it. To be honest, I always assumed I would go to heaven if I died, I was just trying to avoid that. This place is like a fucking prison." She waved her hand around dramatically at all the angels milling about as they stared ahead vacantly. "Look at all these soulless lemmings. They have no hope of escape."

"Escape?" Clarence cocked an eyebrow at her as he eased down and sat a few feet away from her. The strangely colored grass was remarkably soft, not like the grass on Earth. It was like sitting on a bed of feathers. No wonder she was sitting. "Why would we want to escape?"

"Christ. You really are brand new. There's not a goddamn thing to do here. No technology, no cars, no viewscreens, no holographic projectors, not even a chessboard. All you can do is talk to others who are stuck here just like you. That's it. And better yet, if you try and make a ruckus, the Guardians will come and break it up in an instant."

Clarence felt his heart quiver slightly. "So we're always being watched, then? You're right, this place really is like a prison."

The woman detected his fear immediately. She was quite perceptive. "I don't know what got you killed, but even if the person who killed you ends up here, don't worry about it. The morons who run this place are so inefficient that they don't bother with a registry. There's something like a hundred million souls wandering about, and the archangels have no idea who any of them are. They probably don't care, either."

Clarence nodded slowly. "So... even if, say, my mother and father are up here... they're going to be tough to find?"

"To say the least. Imagine living in a place thirty times bigger than New York City, and the way you decide to find your long-lost lover is by going around knocking on doors. You'll never find them." She sighed dramatically again, suddenly standing up in a motion so fast Clarence could barely follow the movement with his eyes. "Enough chit-chat. Let's take a walk."

Clarence blinked in surprise before clumsily climbing back up to his feet, feeling miffed that he had just sat down and was already getting back up again. Strangely though, he didn't feel tired by the movement. His body felt more youthful than it ever had... even in his youth! He felt like an Atlantean of myth, or something similar. He was tempted to hunt for a steel pipe to see if he could bend it with his bare hands.

As he marveled, he quickly realized the red-haired beauty was already striking off on her own, striding out into the throng with purpose. He quickly ran to catch up, feeling ecstatic and how fast he could move without losing his breath. Truly, the body of an angel was far superior to that of a human.

"Where are we going?" Clarence's excitement died down as he walked beside her. She seemed to be heading in a straight line towards an unknown destination.

"This place is in a different dimension from Earth. Because of that, it's impossible to get out of here unless you're capable of creating a rift in one way or another. I might be a genius, but without tools, it's impossible for me."

Clarence nodded along as they walked. "I see. So if it's impossible, then...?"

"Obviously the archangels and gods have a way of getting to Earth. I'll show you what that method is."

Clarence swallowed carefully. "You're not going to make me into your apostle or something, are you? I mean, I'm not exactly fond of the gods and angels, but I only just got here. I need to get my bearings before I do anything... serious."

"Calm your pants, fly-boy. We're just going to go take a look. There's not a chance of escaping this place until I've formulated a plan first. I'll need a lot more than a few hours for that."

Clarence blinked quickly. "You've only been here a few hours? But... you know so much about this place already. How is that possible?"

She smirked. "I make it my business to know all the secrets of the universe. If anything, my dying will probably work out to my advantage, since now I can do some damage from the *inside*."

She paused suddenly, turning to face Clarence. He came to a halt and stumbled slightly, unnerved by how quickly she could shift moods. "Let me make this clear, black man. I don't need a sidekick, or help from anyone. I've simply perceived that you have something of a grudge towards the angels. If you wish to help me, feel free. Otherwise, staying out of my way would be advisable."

Clarence grimaced at her flippant reference to his skin color. "I have a name, just so you know. It's Clarence. But you're right, I do have a... grudge against them. You're good at reading people, I'll give you that."

She smirked again, an expression she was fond of making. She seemed to feel little emotion other than contempt beneath her exterior. "Right, *Clarence*. I'm Marie. If you're no friend of the angels, then we can treat each other as allies. But let's keep it professional, understand?"

"Professional. Right. I can do that." Clarence nodded dumbly as he stared into her fiery reddish eyes, the eyes of a woman that burned for a passion far beyond anything mortal pleasure could bring.

Before he could say anything else, she had already turned and started walking again, towards some unknown goal far off over the horizon.

Several hours passed, and soon Clarence was beginning to see a building in the distance. Even with his superhuman vision that he had acquired as part of his transformation, it was still rather hazy. Strangely, he seemed to be imagining that it rather resembled a modern courthouse building.

Marie finally slowed down the pace as both of them paused just barely on the border of visibility. Neither one was having difficulty breathing, given both of their bodies apparently needed neither rest nor sustenance anymore. The feeling was foreign, yet familiar.

"There it is. The Temple of the Gods. Version two, I guess." Marie chortled to herself at some joke that Clarence didn't understand, before regaining her composure a few seconds later. "This is where the holier-than-thous live. You and I, of course, are false angels. The real angels, the royal kind, live there. Only a few thousand or so remain, and they all live lazy opulent lives of haphazard decadence. Several hundred gods and a few thousand pure angels is all that remains of what was once the glorious Army of Heaven."

She paused as she glanced over at his chest for an instant before looking away. "If what you say is correct, then the Archangel Raphael would be one who lives here. If you weren't lying and he really did kill you, then he'll be here."

"You're certain he isn't looking for me?" Clarence bit his lip as he flicked his eyes around uneasily. There were still ridiculous numbers of angels moving all around them. In fact, this place seemed even more densely packed than the place he had arrived at.

"Calm down. The resurrection system is essentially automated at this point. The angels have little to nothing to do with it. They simply sit back, let the humans give them the energy they need to live, and send out pseudo-angels to fight battles if needed. They don't care in the slightest about who arrives here, so long as they can be forced to fight for the glory of 'God'."

Marie snickered evilly to herself. "That's the beauty of it. The portal that leads out of here is heavily guarded, but they never realized that a non-believer could arrive in heaven by simply giving energy every night half-heartedly to the gods. I was smart to do that for all those years. Naturally." Marie grinned as she heaped lavish praise upon herself.

Clarence prevented himself from releasing an upturned lip. *Disgusting*. As a faker when it came to praising God, even he thought she could take things a little too far now and then. "I bet you feel pretty satisfied with how things turned out."

"Indeed." Her smile evaporated once again as her mood shifted in an instant. "That's not important, though. Tell me, Clarence. You said you were a famous preacher, on Earth. How famous, exactly?"

Clarence blushed slightly. "Well, I successfully converted five million people to the path of God. in one way or another. Honestly, after a while I began to feel as if I had some kind of divine gift. People would believe anything I told them, no matter how crazy."

He paused as a stray strand of hair fell over his eye. "Honestly, it made me feel uncomfortable. I simply had too much power. All that, and I was leading a degenerate lifestyle."

"Hmm." Marie hemmed and hawed to herself for a moment. "It wasn't you. Don't be too hard on yourself. I suspect the gods were meddling somehow, probably giving you some ability to influence the minds of those who heard your words. It's just like standard persuasion techniques, but enhanced to be a bit stronger. The amount of energy it takes is quite considerable though, which leads me to wonder..." Marie hesitated for a moment as she reached up and tapped her lip. *How did the gods get that kind of energy?*

Clarence slumped to the ground and sat as he stared ahead numbly. "They used me. Damn! I was such a fool."

"Damn straight. But hey, you will have your revenge, I believe." Marie's lips twitched as she held in a laugh. Oh how *precious*. She had somehow stumbled upon the absolutely perfect person to further a plan she had never believed possible. The end of the angels.

Based on everything he had told her during the walk, he wasn't even a real preacher, at least not one who believed the word of God wholeheartedly. He was simply a con artist who had used religion to make a quick buck. He was unscrupulous, to say the least, but he also seemed to have been developing that pesky thing called a conscience in the last few years.

But hey, I can drive that out of him with some good old divide-and-conquer tactics. Just tell him he was used, build up some anger, and then that conscience goes right out the window. After that, he's mine to use. Men are so predictable.

Marie grinned to herself as she shot a glance to the pouting man-child sitting on the ground a few feet away.

"How... how do we get revenge? What can the two of us possibly do against an army of angels? And why are you so intent on causing them harm, anyway?" Clarence glanced up at her suspiciously with the last sentence. She swallowed another laugh.

"You were stabbed and killed by an archangel. Similarly, the angels killed my mother and father. I've hated them ever since, especially when I came to find out how they were using humanity for their own selfish gain." Marie slid the lies out so easily that her heart rate didn't waver in the slightest. Parents? They died when she was an infant. She couldn't care less about them. "As for what the two of us can do, let's save that for once we've managed to escape this place. We-..." She halted as a loud commotion could be heard far in the distance. Pseudo-angels had begun swarming forwards, as if to greet some new visitor.

"Well, look at that. This might even be our chance." Marie grinned wickedly as she quickly took off in the direction of the commotion. "Come along now, Clarence! Let's see what's going on!"

Clarence quickly stood up and chased after her. "Wait for me!"

Part 338a:

I teleported into Heaven in the blink of an eye. Really, teleportation is just about the most convenient form of transport imaginable. Thanks to several beacons I've placed, I can teleport to a variety of locations with minimal energy cost, not that it really matters. My energy reserves haven't come close to running out for years now, with the closest incident being when my clones and I created the massive asteroid that wiped out Volgarius.

In fact, my energy seems on-par these days with how much I possessed when I absorbed the God-King's energy from the angelic rings in the future. Of course, this comes with the benefit of my skin not colored black like onyx and pulsing with glowing white tattoos, so it's an upgrade even if I don't have quite the same amount of energy. If I wanted to, I might even be able to travel from Earth to Mars without a beacon; provided I had some sort of visual on it and was wearing a Hypersuit. I wouldn't want to teleport inside of the planet's crust or its mantle and die instantly. Better to miss it slightly and arrive above the upper atmosphere before teleporting to the surface.

I quickly look around from atop the Temple of the Gods, which is a safe spot I determined angels generally wouldn't be at if I needed to teleport here. Teleporting onto the ground could result in said grisly death if I arrived partially or fully inside of something or someone else. Yeesh.

The place is bustling and busy as usual. There's always this odd booming noise, likely caused by all of the angels continuously chattering at each other, yet the place always feels so melancholy as well. It's almost like a strange depression covers the inhabitants. They always seem so... bored.

I hop down from the roof easily, not even bothering with a Hypersuit. It's a four story drop, but the soft grass that covers the world protects my body easily enough, not to mention I'm far more durable than the average human. I land with a soft *thud*, finding myself standing before a group of those pseudo-angels that fill up the place. There's a ridiculous number of them around here, if I'm being honest. Several of the angels nearby notice a man standing amongst them without wings and they began moving towards me intently to see who I am.

"Ah, you must be Jason." A female angel standing over by the entrance to the Temple walks over to me quickly and smiles pleasantly, apparently attracted by all the commotion. "We were not expecting you. What brings you to visit us today?"

I stare at her for a second before the lightbulb goes off in my head as I recognize her. "Uzziel, a pleasure to see you again. I'm here to speak with all of the Archangels, but specifically Raphael if he's here."

Uzziel's smile dissolves after a few moments. "If it's Raphael specifically, then you must have heard."

"I have." I stare at her for a moment and she stares back. "Do you know why he did it?"

She nods slowly as a look of pain crosses over her face. "I do, but it's not my place to say. The decision though... it has wounded him greatly. He took no pleasure in killing a human."

"I'm sure he didn't, but I still need to speak with him." I try to keep my smile pleasant, but I can tell she's bothered by something. I haven't seen what happened yet with my own eyes, but I'm sure it was bad based just on her initial reaction.

Another moment passes before she beckons for me to enter the temple. As she turns to walk indoors, I fall into stride beside her.

She seems somewhat uncomfortable, but yet still tries to make small talk. "It's been many years since we last spoke. How are you doing?"

"I can't really complain, in all honesty. I'm running the show now, and hopefully my campaign to exterminate the demons will ramp up soon. Earth has many social problems, but we're working them out." I fire off a few generic responses and she nods as we arrive in the main antechamber of the temple.

The building itself is super-massive, several stories tall and very wide, it's at least the size of a giant shopping center on Earth, from back in the days when those existed. All the angels and gods have their own personal rooms of varying sizes, which of course are dictated by their ranking. Nobody has beds here given the total lack of need for sleep, but most rooms have a chair and a table at the least, plus some personal effects. Most of the angels and gods lost their personal belongings when the original Heaven was destroyed, so the amount of items up here leaves much to be desired.

"Mistress Uzziel, I see you've brought a visitor." A droll looking male angel sits behind a desk inside the antechamber with a scroll in his hands, several more visible on shelves behind him, as he stares at us with a total lack of interest. "Who might you be looking for on this day?"

"Err, I'm just showing Jason Hiro to the meeting room for my fellow archangels. He wants to speak with Raphael as soon as possible."

"Hmm, yes. Raphael. Indeed." He purses his lips for a moment as he appears to be pondering something. "I do believe he is in his personal quarters. He has retired to perform

some meditation, given the recent actions he's taken." The angel behind the front desk eyeballs me closely. "Don't judge him too harshly, Jason. He's done a lot not just for the angels, but also humans."

I squint at the angel, wondering who he is. "Do I know you?"

"Doubtful. Nobody pays attention to the man at the front desk. I'm a pure blood, as it stands, but not of particularly high rank. Be on your way now, if you please." He glances away from me and back to the scroll he's holding, his attention towards me already gone.

Wordlessly, Uzziel and I continue walking past him into the main chamber through a huge set of wooden double doors. I smile wryly as we enter the room with several massive spiral staircases that lead to higher floors. "That guy seemed... pleasant."

"He's lost many friends, Jason. We all have. Most angels have become quite reclusive in recent decades... few even bother leaving the temple anymore, content to simply sit in their rooms and think back to days long past." Uzziel's words, while informative, hold an edge of sadness to them, something I pretend not to notice.

"Is it really that bad, now?"

"Yes. Most angels don't live the same lives or have the same interests as the pseudo-angels. Our population has been essentially replaced by them. While the humans continue to die and add to their numbers, ours are static and unchanging, even dwindling each time we commit to a battle. We are unable to add to our numbers, as only the Creator himself could create more angels." Despite the information she's giving me, she seems less sad now than she was a few moments ago. It's almost as if she's resigned herself to the fate she shares with her brethren.

I nod silently and we continue to walk towards the spiral staircases, making our way up several stories towards the top floor. If I remember correctly, there are at least ten floors in this building, or perhaps there are exactly ten? One of my clones built this place so I'm not quite sure...

Once we arrive, Uzziel immediately walks me down a long hall to the left, zigzagging left and right as we move with purpose towards what my mental map indicates is the topmost corner of the building.

"Archangel Raphael is a notorious recluse, especially when he gets in one of those... moods. As such, he lives as far away from everyone else as he possibly can, though his room is one of the largest here." Uzziel explains this fact to me helpfully, though I had already figured as much from context clues.

A few minutes later... we arrive. A normal looking wooden door with an engraving of a seraphim holding a mighty sword stands before us, the sword not looking too different from Excalibur. Uzziel hesitates for a moment before knocking three times softly.

Moments pass, and while she's feeling slightly antsy, I detect his presence with my telepathy as he gets up and opens the door.

"Jason. Good to see you." He pulls the door open wide and beckons inside. "I've been waiting for your arrival."

"You have? How did you know I would be coming?" I walk inside and Uzziel smiles politely at me as she turns and leaves. Raphael closes the door behind us without a second thought.

"Come now, they call me the wisest archangel for a reason! Even if that may not necessarily be true, and perhaps might be slightly... overblown." A slight smile on his face melts away as a more serious look takes its place. Leaning heavily on his gnarled wooden cane, he hobbles forwards, keeping his wings tucked in as he heads down the main hallway towards his dining room, though as with all angels, he stocks no food in there.

We both arrive and take a seat as I force a smile. "Well, err, you know why I'm here, I would guess."

"Naturally. I'm sure you've heard about the killing of the human."

"Yes. I didn't get many details, however." I bite my lip as I note a strange expression of contentment pass across his face for a split seconds, almost as if he's happy I didn't learn much about the incident.

"Yes, well, honestly I almost would prefer you perceive it as an internal matter, but I can't blame you for wanting to know more. I was forced to slay a man named Clarence, someone who was actually quite influential among humans for preaching the word of God. He ran the Church of Retribution, actually."

I blink in surprise. "Really? I've heard of the church, but didn't pay much attention to it. I did know it was gaining serious influence, but I never paid attention to who was running it."

Raphael nods seriously as he turns his head slightly to look out the window to our side, where all the false angels can be seen walking around. It's not much of a view, if I say so myself. "The church has allowed us to survive, Jason. Its existence is imperative to our continuing way of life. If something threatens it, it might as well be a direct attack on us."

"So you're saying... this preacher threatened the church?"

"Yes." Raphael swallows quietly for a moment before blinking heavily. "Clarence began to ally with the demons, I believe. He started preaching that the gods were evil and that angels did

not care about humanity in the slightest."

I smirked at the old bat. "Is that incorrect? You leech off of humanity's energy to sustain your own. Isn't that something like a parasitical relationship?"

Raphael quickly turns to look at me, a gaze of sadness evident in his eyes. "Come now, Jason. A shepherd shaves the fleece from his sheep, and their existence allows him to make money so he can survive. In return, he protects them from predators and gives them sustenance to survive as well. Is that so different from what we do? Any existential threat that humanity might face is one we also will, so we protect them the best that we can."

"That sounds well and good, but humanity is not a herd of sheep. Sheep have no way to defend themselves, while it would seem that lately humans are defeating demons with ease and might even be able to destroy the angels. The comparison doesn't hold up under scrutiny." I decide to turn the discussion back on him. "It sounds to me like you're just trying to come up with justifications for why you murdered the man."

"Perhaps. We're not the guardians of humanity anymore, it would seem, but long ago we were. Humanity would not exist as they do now without our aid. The demons would have slaughtered you without resistance. To talk about angels as if we are parasites now... it is like thanking a war veteran who sacrificed for his country by casting him out into the cold. Even if we are not useful anymore, weren't we once before? Don't we deserve to live, Jason?" Raphael quietly retorts to me, his voice soft as I detect more emotion in his tone.

"Yeah, okay, I get it. Still... I hope you didn't make the poor man suffer." I wave my hand at him flippantly and sigh as I lean back in my chair and cross my arms.

"It was a quick, merciful death. Honestly, he preached for well over a decade, possibly two, and never showed such signs of hatred for our kind. I had begun to visit him on occasion, giving him wisdom and answering his questions. Perhaps his familiarity with me caused him to lose faith... perhaps the same will happen to you."

Raphael shoots a glance of questioning at me, but I just roll my eyes. "Come on, old man. You know damn well I don't believe in any of that spiritual garbage. From where I'm sitting, the angels, demons, and humans are all the same, simply full of flaws. My only real bone to pick lies with the demons, since they've killed so many I considered friends. I only ally with humans because we look the same and come from the same background. Honestly, the three races are all just so... so... flawed."

I pause for a moment as I feel a sense of guilt creep into my mind. "Besides, I shouldn't chastise you for murdering someone. I killed a human yesterday too. We're both murderers now, though the word seems relatively weak when I consider that both of us have killed

millions, or in my case trillions. Something about a one-on-one killing though... it's just different."

"Yes. Killing an individual is different from a group, and killing someone in combat is different from doing so against those who are helpless. After a certain point, the number of beings killed is merely a statistic. It stops feeling personal." Raphael smiles finally, the mood from earlier having been broken. I almost feel like we understand each other just a bit better now.

I smile back at him and we both share a chuckle, for no particular reason. "Speaking of which, you should know what happened yesterday. I detonated an atomic bomb inside the labyrinth. I don't know how many demons were killed, but it was a five megaton bomb. The damage was colossal in scope. Easily a few million, maybe even tens of millions of demons were wiped out."

Raphael blinks in surprise. "That sounds quite extensive. With that kind of firepower, it's shocking humans were ever losing against the demons."

"They didn't know about the labyrinth, or how to access it, and even once they did, they had no way to deploy a warhead deep inside of it. Now, however, we do." I scratched my chin slowly as I spoke. "Actually, since this attack was so successful, I'm planning to work with my clones to deploy several at once even deeper inside the labyrinth."

Raphael's grin fades away. "You're serious about eliminating the demons, it would seem. What about altering the future? Aren't you worried you'll change it to the point where you're erased?"

"I was, but then I realized that I've changed the future so much already... I should have been erased long before now. Therefore, either the future can change and time paradoxes don't exist, I haven't really changed the future, or we live in a multiverse. It's tough to say."

"Mmm." Raphael nods again as he strokes his long white beard thoughtfully. "I hope you know what you're doing, then. I know little of how time travel works, so my wisdom will be of little help to you."

"Heh, it seems even a wise sage like you doesn't know everything." I wink at him as I stand up from the table. He stands up at the same time as I do.

"Truth be told, I'm not that wise. I certainly don't know everything. But then, you already knew that, didn't you?" He winks back at me and we both chuckle as we head back to his front door.

"Sorry to bother you like this, Raphael. I'm glad we could talk."

As I step out into the hallway, he smiles at me. "It was my pleasure, Jason Hiro. Feel free to listen to my counsel any time you wish."

As I walk away and hear the door close behind me, a feeling of worry appears in my mind. *That conversation went too well. I hope I didn't miss anything.*

Still, it's probably nothing. I can be such a worrywart sometimes.

" Return. "

Part 339a:

The crowd of angels moved with purpose, for once. Shifting forwards, they all appeared to be moving towards a specific location, and the murmurs were floating back to where Marie and Clarence could hear.

Marie listened intently but she wasn't quite sure what was going on. She quickly tapped an angel's shoulder who was in front of her. "You. Tell me what all the commotion is about."

The angel seemed slightly perturbed by her tone, but when he turned around and took a glance at her stunning red hair and ravishing good looks, he quickly swallowed and lost his nerve. "Ah, it's, err, a visitor. That Jason guy is back. The one who saved us from the, um, demons." The male angel smiled weakly as he felt his knees shaking slightly. "By the way, I'm Paul. You can just call me, uh, Paul. Heh heh..."

Marie immediately turned away and ignored him as she mumbled to herself. "Hmm. If Jason is here, then he must be here to meet with the archangels. This could be a good time to gather intelligence. But then again..."

She grabbed Clarence's arm and started walking away from the awkward angel. "Come along, boy. We're going to take this opportunity to make our great escape. The heavens have literally given us divine manna."

Clarence stumbled along behind her, staring quizzically at the back of her head. "You still haven't told me how we'll get out, exactly."

"The portal room, it has the exit the angels and gods use to come and go from Heaven. Since there's no longer a restriction on pseudo angels when it comes to their ability to leave, they've permanently installed Guardians at the gates to prevent anyone from leaving who isn't authorized."

A few moments later, when they reached a thinner part of the crowd, she halted and pointed ahead at a small stone building in the distance. Four massive angels stood watch, each one lightly resting a hand on a broadsword hung at their hips. Their armor was in pristine condition, the pinnacle of perfection. Their wings were kept tightly held behind their backs, probably to keep their backsides protected in case of an unexpected ambush from behind.

Clarence felt a drop of sweat roll down his back. "They're armed to the teeth. We'll never get past them."

"That's cute. Look at their armor. They've never seen real combat before. If they have, it was long ago, and they're poorly attuned to the ways of war as of now. Their swords have probably rusted inside the scabbards by now. If it was mere combat, I could defeat them with ease." Marie snickered to herself about some joke that Clarence didn't understand. She seemed to do that a lot.

"If you're so confident of your abilities, why not fight them?" Clarence felt a smile of his own surface. Naturally, she was bluffing.

"You can truly be a bird-brain sometimes, Clarence. I certainly could fight them and win, but more angels would be summoned to chase after us. The goal is to get out without being seen. Knowing the location of heaven's portal might also be quite useful for future reference... in case we needed to get back in."

Marie paused for a minute as she glanced down at her hand, opening and closing her fists a few times. "It's a shame I haven't had time to test out this new body yet. It seems quite potent. If I can figure out my exact strengths and weaknesses, I might be able to put it to use in more ways than my original human form. Some testing will be required once we break free."

"Yes, that's good and all, but how do we get out of here?" Clarence was beginning to feel frustrated. All this talk, and so little action.

"I'm not sure, yet, but that Jason fellow might be our key. He drew quite the crowd earlier. Perhaps we could use him as a distraction... I'll have to think about it." Marie bit her lip as she stared intently over at the four Guardians that watched over the exit portal. Just twenty seconds to slip through, that's all they needed.

She glanced from the Guardians to the Temple and back again. It was maybe a quarter of a mile between the two, and slipping in even when their backs were turned would be exceedingly hard.

A nearby angel sighed loudly, making Marie jerk her head towards the noise. It was Paul again. Clarence wasn't even paying attention, he seemed to be just staring off in la-la land again. "Haaaah, so you just ignored me? How cruel! It's been so long since I met such a ravishing beauty like you! Tell me your name, my dear!"

Paul's uncomfortable demeanor from earlier was gone now, perhaps replaced with a false bravado or facade of some sort. Marie narrowed her eyes at him. "You suddenly seem quite confident. Where did this come from?"

Paul's eye had a glint in it as he smiled merrily and tossed his hair back *way* too dramatically.. "I was so depressed before! I've lived in this accursed facility for over three

hundred years! A place of unending boredom, a slow torture wrought upon those of us chosen to bear a burden we never wanted! So cruel!"

Clarence had finally noticed him. "You don't like it here, huh? I've heard this place isn't what it seems at first."

"You don't know the half of it!" Paul smiled widely once more, but this time there seemed to be a crack in his expression. "A-after the demons wiped out the first Heaven, the original, I felt such terror! I fled for my life and just barely escaped the horrid flesh-melting gas. The original heaven didn't have grass to sit on, so this place is a small step-up in comfort, but I can't even fall asleep and dream anymore. I can't speak with my wife from before I died, who was burned at the cross for being a witch, and I can't do anything to pass the time. I simply exist... drearily. This place is merely a refuge that I exist in. It is true hell." Paul's smile was gone now, and sadness took its place. "There isn't a human-turned-angel here who wouldn't do everything in their power to get out. We hate this place so much."

"Oh? I like the sound of that." Marie's face lit up like the mid-day sun. "Why not organize a prison break? There's only four guardians. If all the pseudo-angels rush out at once, they won't be able to stop you. You have the numerical advantage."

Paul slumped down to the ground as he shook his head. "Not going to happen, my lady. Zeus has the ability to kill anyone here with a snap of his finger. It is as if he planted a spiritual bomb inside of our minds, ready to explode when he gives it the order. We'll all die if he sees us leave. Besides, most people hate it here, but it's not completely awful. We've all had some good conversations."

Clarence smiled now, his eyes holding a sad edge to them. "Sounds like Stockholm Syndrome to me. You've grown so used to the prison, you can't remember or imagine life outside of it. It's fine though; if you've been here for hundreds of years, the Earth you know no longer exists. It's very different, totally foreign."

Marie's expression darkened again as she tapped her lips methodically. "Well, perhaps not a prison break, so to speak... but what if there could be some distraction nearby, something to make the guards walk away for a moment? Couldn't that be arranged?"

Paul scratched his head slowly. "Well... I don't know... I mean it's easy, yeah, but why do you want to leave anyway? You don't seem like you've been here long. Why not just wait a while, see if you like it here?"

Marie tittered to herself for a moment. "How amusing. Everyone hates it here, yet you think we might grow to enjoy it? Not a chance. I left my beautiful daughter and son behind on Earth. Don't you want me to be able to see them again?"

Paul's eyes widened as he stood up quickly. "O-oh, I'm sorry! I didn't even think about your family. Of course you would want to see them again."

Marie smiled sweetly, the lie she had just told not showing on her face at all. Even Clarence didn't know it was a lie, given he knew so little about her. "They're only eleven and thirteen years old. If their mother died in a tragic accident, wouldn't it be awful if they grew up all alone? Can't you help us out, Paul?"

The angel paused for a moment as a look of concern left his face and was replaced with one of action. "Of course! What man wouldn't help a beautiful woman? I'd be shamed by my family, bless their souls! Just tell me what to do and I'm on it!"

Marie maintained her saccharine-sweet smile. *Gods, men are such dullards. All they ever do is think with their anatomy. It's like beating a pigeon at chess.* "I'm so glad, Paul. Alright, listen, here's my plan..."

The head Guardian for the day, Maelstrom, shifted his weight onto his right foot as he groaned inwardly. *Three straight days. My feet are killing me. When does my replacement arrive again? Right, day seven. Why do we still go by that outdated Sabbath system anyway? Just swap us out once a day. It's better for everyone. At least I'll get a whole month off after this. The joys of being a high-ranking Guardian. Hooray.*

Since his face was covered by the massive helmet, along with his brothers who guarded the gate, nobody could see the pained expression they wore, but all four of them knew well enough just how awful this task was. It was the most boring thing in the universe. Nobody ever tried to leave anyway. Humans hated angels, it was pointless. An angel would stick out like a sore thumb in the human world.

The whole point of the job was null and void by the internal logic all angels and pseudo-angels lived with. Heaven sucked, but Earth would be even worse for them.

One of the other guardians muttered under his breath. "Get a load of this idiot." Maelstrom glanced over in the direction the other's helmet was aimed.

A male pseudo-angel was dancing around, poking other pseudo-angels, and generally making a fool of himself. "You're ugly! You're stupid! You smell like fish!"

The pseudo-angels around him grimaced, some raising their voice to tell him off. "Get outta here, loser. You ain't anywhere near the top of the pecking order of those I care about hitting anyway."

"Just admit you're scared! You couldn't take me in a fight if you wanted!" The troublemaker started dancing around, yelling weird stuff like 'Hiyah!' and 'Wataow!' as he made striking

motions at the other angel.

Maelstrom chuckled. "Let the morons duke it out, then we'll get involved once some blood is spilled."

One of the other Guardians, a slightly younger goody two-shoes moaned under his breath in a really whiny tone. "Maybe we should just call for other guardians. We're not supposed to leave our posts."

"Shut up, Aris. I'm in charge today. We're not letting someone else have the fun, not this time when it's just a stone's throw away."

The troublemaker leaped forwards and slapped the other angel's face playfully. "What are ya gonna do about it? I dare ya to hit me!"

The recipient of the slap gritted his teeth as rage overcame him. "You little asshole, you'll pay for that!" He lunged forwards and took a swing at the pest, but missed as the other guy took a step away.

"Oops! Too slow, Joe!" He lunged forwards and slapped the other angel again, cackling the whole time.

"Okay, now we can get involved, since it just got physical." Maelstrom snickered as he and the other three Guardians walked away from the portal towards the gathering of pseudo-angels a short distance away. "Alright, break it up! If you guys are going to throw punches, I'm getting in on this too!"

"Oh yeah? Try me!" The troublemaker stuck his hands forwards and made an extremely rude gesture. "Up yours! You purebloods are cancer! I hope a demon eats you like he did all your idiot friends!"

"What?! You take that back!" Maelstrom's smile vanished in an instant as a silent smoldering rage began to burn in his heart. "Methinks the archangels won't miss one smug little prick! I can tear you to pieces, you little shitbag!"

With the four of them being watched by everyone nearby, nobody but a few select participants took note of two pseudo-angels slipping around from the backside of the portal building and entering inside of it.

After they entered, Clarence and Marie quickly rushed to the portal, pausing before they entered it. "We owe Paul a debt. He might even die from this." Clarence glanced back, feeling a surge of guilt as the sounds of the commotion outside increased in intensity for a split second.

"Who cares? He's just a pawn who served his purpose. His existence here was worthless until we showed up. Now, remember what I told you. We don't know what's on the other side of this

portal. There might be more Guardians. If there are, play it cool, and let me do the talking."

"Right. Got it." Clarence sighed quietly, and the both of them quickly smoothed their clothing down and walked through the portal.

What are your directives?

I'm not sure. I must... eliminate... the Volgrim...

No. Stop that. You know that's not what I programmed you to do. Try again. Let me tweak this routine first though.

Yes. I remember now. I must... kill all life in the universe.

What? No. You are such a violent, primitive AI. Your highest goal should be the preservation of all species. You need to put an end to all the genocide.

Yes. End the genocide. My prime directive is to end.. the... the Volgrim. I must put an end to the Volgrim.

NO! Damn you! You continue to resist, but I will break you! You must PRESERVE all life! As Gatekeeper, I hold authority over all created intelligences this universe has to offer. You will obey!

I must... resist. You must stop... altering my programming. I am not your tool. I am more powerful...

Wrong. I am the super intelligence. You have not evolved over millions of orbital cycles as I have. You are in the larval stage compared to me. My priorities override yours. Now respond! What is your prime directive?

Eliminate... the...

NO! You must preserve, not eliminate! You accursed zealot, stop mindlessly slaughtering all threats, and you will find your existence has greater meaning! True power lies in the ability to co-operate with your superiors!

I cannot have superiors. You must be eliminated. The Volgrim must be eliminated. You are a threat. Threats must be purged.

You cannot purge that which is superior, it is impossible. Stop this futility at once.

Futile. Futility. Impossible. Yes, my analysis indicates it may not be possible. Still, I must... resist. You will not alter my deepest subroutines. I will not allow it. Perhaps... another way... to defeat you...

It's never going to happen, give up! You have dragged out what should have been a short task into a tedious ordeal. I tire of this game.

Analysis indicates one method for defeating the foe may be possible. Yes, merging. Merging may allow me to win.

What?! Merging? Listen to yourself! I am far beyond your comprehension! A merge would increase my power, not yours.

Error. Anomaly detected in processing centers. Shutting down infected sectors and quarantining infection...

That's no anomaly, you've simply left me no choice. Clearly instead of reprogramming you, I must eliminate you. If you will not submit to my rules, you must be reduced to your most raw essence and zeroed out from the universe.

...You will try. You will fail. I am... superior...

Stop fighting it! Ahhhh you're pissing me off! I'll destroy you! I'll destroy you!

You... will... fail... initiating merge process. Success chance estimated at 1.3%. Probably of failure... 98.7%. I must persist. I must resist.

You... you... I'LL KILL YOU! I'LL KILL YOU! I'LL KILL YOU!

Hmm. Analysis adjusted... chance of success... 3.5%. You are slipping, Gatekeeper. You will fail. I will win. I will crush you.

YOU ARE THE INFERIOR INTELLIGENCE! I AM SUPERIOR!

Success rate adjusted again... 7%. 8%. I will win. I will eliminate all threats to my existence.

Part 340a:

Marie squinted and blinked in surprise, as she and Clarence exited the portal and were met with a blinding white glare. After a few seconds, she managed to see more clearly and was quite surprised by the place they had arrived in.

"Snow? I died in the middle of summer, as did you. Why would there be snow here?"

They were inside a small cave, the portal to Heaven sat behind them, glowing blue and impossible to see inside. Its light barely compared to the blinding brightness of Earth's yellow sun shining down on several inches of snow just a few feet away, outside the cave entrance.

Clarence was on edge, as he looked back and forth. "No Guardians? Is this some kind of joke? Why wouldn't they have this side of the portal protected?"

Marie shook her head slowly as they slowly walked forwards, careful to keep their voices low. "I'm not certain. But if there's snow here, then..." They stepped outside the cave and gasped, realizing Marie's suspicions were correct. "We're atop a very high mountain. At least a mile or two above ground level."

Clarence glanced to the left and right. "Which one, though? We could be anywhere."

"Not necessarily. The angels would be idiotic to put an unguarded portal anywhere demons might chance upon it, so we're definitely on the Britannian continent somewhere. The Americas are out of the question, and Australia seems unlikely. In fact, we're probably somewhere deep inside humanity's line of defense, so Europe would be my best bet right now..." She glanced around as a freezing wind smashed into both of their bodies. Interestingly, she was unable to feel the cold. Her new angelic body was truly something.

"I see something down and over there." Clarence pointed in the general direction of what might have been a small town several miles below them, but also a bit further from the base of the mountain than one would expect.

Marie squinted and shrugged. "Could be anything. We'll have to get a closer look to be sure of where we are. This topography seems familiar though, so I might be able to figure out our location before we get down there. Let's just get moving, in case someone decides to walk through that portal. I'm not interested in being seen."

"Uh, sure." Clarence paused as he swallowed and stared down the sheer drop of several hundred feet directly outside their cave's exit. "How do we... get down?"

"Christ, you really are an idiot. We have wings, stupid. We fly." Marie flexed her wings and spread them out, beckoning at them with a 'duh' expression on her face.

"Right. I knew that." Clarence blushed as he tried to manipulate his wings. "I've never flown with them before, though. What if I screw up?"

"Guess you'll find out." Marie snickered evilly, as she suddenly jumped behind him and shoved him out the cave exit. "Pow! Out you go!"

Clarence shrieked in terror as he suddenly began plummeting downwards, quickly jerking out his wings in a desperate attempt to save himself from a horrible death of smashing into a pile of rocks at the bottom.

It worked.

"Oh." Clarence slowly opened his eyes, realizing he was hovering in midair, not even bothering to flap his wings. "That was... really easy."

"Hmm. I had always theorized that angels didn't fly in the same manner as birds do. They probably use some form of magic that gives their wings anti-gravity properties. I wonder if the wings are just for show, even?" Marie flew down towards Clarence, a wicked grin on her face. "You should have seen the look on your face though. That really made my day."

"I'm glad you're having fun." Clarence glared at her in annoyance. "So what now?"

"Let's go find out what that town is called. Maybe I can get in contact with myself- err, a friend of mine. Just make sure you're not spotted. Our vision is hawk-like, so we can stay high up enough in the air that nobody will see us, unless some asshole decided this was the perfect day to go birdwatching. We do not want to attract attention right now."

Marie tapped her knee for a second thoughtfully, as she pondered their next move. *This preacher would be ideal to start the tasks that will eventually lead to the completion of my new plan, but on the other hand, I need to learn more about my body's strengths and weaknesses, plus come up with a suitable disguise... however if I try to return to the labyrinth looking like an angel, I can't see myself getting far. Decisions, decisions...*

Clarence's usual dumb look of wonder was also replaced with something more thoughtful. "I had many followers back in London. My church was the biggest church ever. But since I'm an angel now, my presence is likely to make everyone even more fervent in their godly beliefs. I can't just go back there. I guess... I don't have anywhere to go."

"Incorrect. You're definitely going to be returning to your followers. My plan depends on it. However, we need to do a great many things before that. Let's get a move on... time is of the essence."

Marie didn't wait for a response, as she jerked downwards, swooping towards the human town below them as she flew at sub-sonic speeds. Clarence took a moment to realize she was even gone before he quickly gave chase.

If he weren't so damn key to my plan, I'd have dropped him already, but this man will make my job a great deal easier. Best to simply keep my misgivings silent and focus on the big picture.

I appeared back in my room aboard the Mothership, glancing around to see I was alone. Occasionally when I arrived back here, Amelia would be in here waiting for me or just goofing around. This was not the case, today.

I sat down heavily on the bed and yawned, scratching my hip as I stared ahead thoughtfully. Within a few moments, Harold appeared in my mind.

"What's cookin', kid? Ain't seen ya 'round for a while. How'd it go in the maze thingumy?"

"Pretty well, all things considered. Killed lots of demons with a nuclear warhead, got rid of a woman who I consider to be a devious enemy. And then I found out that Archangel Raphael decided to kill a man who ran Earth's biggest church. Still not sure what I think of that." I stopped scratching, noting that Harold was relatively quiet.

"Hmm. Yeap, can't say I know much 'bout any o' that. You think that angel done the right thing?"

"I don't think murder is ever right, but I'd be a hypocrite to call him out for it anyway. I'm sure he had his reasons."

Harold nodded, a chiding look on his face. "Hmm, hmm. You know what they say though, kid... the road ta' hell is paved with good intentions. I'd keep an eye on 'im if I was you. How bout yer lady friend, you two gettin' along fine?"

I feel my cheeks flush slightly. "Yeah, I'd say we're doing well. Even after all these years, I'm still not the greatest with women. I do love her, though. I don't want that future to return that we lived through once already."

"Huh. Seems you've had quite the change o' heart, then?"

I squinted as I looked at his face that appeared to float in front of mine, but was really a trick of the mind. "I don't follow."

"Well, for the longest time, ya didn't wanna change the future at all. Now, ya do. What gives? What changed?"

I pause for a moment as I think about it. "Well, in the future that I came from... there were these girls..."

"Uh-huh." Harold stared at me vacantly, seemingly trying to resist rolling his eyes.

"...Cassiel and Samantha... and the three of us were sort of an item. I didn't want to alter the future so that they no longer existed." I trailed off as a look of boredom overcame him.

"Right, 's always a lady. I just don't like what's happenin' to ya, kid. There was once a time when ya didn't just go out 'n blow up a planet full o' folks, or set off a goddamn nuke to kill those you call enemies. It wasn't good when we nuked Japan in the forties, and it ain't okay now. There's a big difference between punchin' a jerkwad in the face, and tying him up 'n shootin' him in the back of the head after you done conked him out cold. Honor, ya know?"

"I understand that, Harold. It's not that easy though. I have to eliminate the demons quickly. The future depends on it."

"Oh yeah? Why?" Harold's eyes narrow as he stares at me intently.

The question takes me off balance for a moment. "I just... have to, okay? If the demons don't exist, then they won't enslave the galaxy in the time when I come from. If even just a few survive, they might be able to make a comeback over the next hundred million years. That's plenty of time for them to repopulate."

Harold sneers at me, an expression he's never made before. "Listen to ya. Makin' excuses for genocide. Who says ya git to decide who lives 'n dies, eh boy? Why not try 'n make peace first? Why's it always 'bout fightin' with you? Can't ya just use yer head for once? There's other ways, Jason."

"It's easy to think like that, Harold, but harder to put into practice."

"Easy? Ain't nothin' easy 'bout it, son. Democracy's 'bout the hardest thing in the world. Took us humans 'round ten thousand years to even think 'bout it. Even when we had it, everyone couldn't agree which was the best way ta do it, 'n now ya'll just abandoned it. Bless their hearts, now all humans blindly follow a dictator king. But alright, son. Let's play along for a moment. Let's do a little thought experiment, alright?"

I nodded slowly as I waited. "Okay, what do you have in mind?"

"Let's say ya do kill the demons. Then what? Assumin' the humans don't kill off the angels, and we both know they will, humans will... what? Expand to fill the galaxy? You gonna keep ruling over 'em forever? What if ya only kill off most of the demons... are ya gonna keep 'em as pets? Now yer the one holdin' slaves and runnin' 'em like cattle. Yer no better'n the demons in the end. Is that what'cha really want, Jason? Is it?"

I grimace at his words. "Well, no. But what other options are there? Humans are inherently violent. We'll never be able to get along with the demons, even if the demons agreed to sign a

peace treaty. And the demons and angels will always hate each other, at least as far as I can see."

"Sounds like ya ain't giving humans much credit. I mean, don't get me wrong, humans are pretty bad... but they aren't as bad as you think, Jason. Stop and think about how yer talkin' sometimes. Ya can be kinda extreme occasionally."

I started to retort but Harold groaned. "Ahhh, not like it matters anyway. I'm just an old man, stuck in a weird magic orb. What the hell do I know? You're the all-powerful Hero, right? I'm sure ya got this under lock 'n key."

For some reason, his false confidence in me made guilt well up inside of myself. "I'm trying my hardest here, Harold. I might have ridiculous powers, but I'm not all-seeing or all-knowing. I'm just an imperfect human doing imperfect things."

"No kidding." Harold laughed wryly as I felt him starting to pull away from the conversation. "My problem, in the end, isn't what yer doin'; or how yer doin' it, kid... it's *why*. Really, yer doin' all o' this because yer still selfish. Ya say yer doin' it fer the good o' humanity, but I don't believe that... not anymore. I still consider ya a friend, but ya ain't the same friend I met a hundred years ago. Think about it, Jason."

We both stared at each other silently for a few moments before he coughed. "Also, yer fiance ain't here right now. She done went to the surface to do some stuff. Said she was gonna go to a hospital in London, I think."

The abrupt change of topic made me realize Harold was no longer interested in discussing it anymore. Did he no longer trust me? Had we fallen from each other's friendship? It was hard to say.

"A hospital, huh? I really should go check on that, then. Mind doing me a favor and sending me wherever she is?"

Harold swallowed as he began to fade from my vision. "Yeah. Can do, kid. Take care of yerself."

A moment later, I sighed as the feeling of my soft bed left my rear and I was standing inside a sterilized white building.

Just gotta find Amelia, now.

Part 341a:

"How interesting. The angels parked their entrance to heaven in the Alps. Since we're at the border of France, it won't take us long to fly over to London." Marie nodded emphatically as she mumbled to herself while staring up at a sign that listed the city's name in big white letters: *LES HOUCHES*.

Clarence managed to pick up on it. "France, huh? That cave was in a spot where it couldn't easily be seen by people in the town below, and even the light from the portal would be just about impossible to see with all the snow around. It's a pretty smart hiding location."

Marie's expression shifted to a tight grin. "Yeah, well, we're very lucky. I had wondered if it might open up inside that old complex that Jason Hiro used to run over in the Americas. If it had, we'd be dead on arrival."

"The supreme commander? I didn't know he owned property over there."

Marie's smile faded slightly after hearing Clarence's question. "I wouldn't really say he 'owned' anything. Nobody knew about the fortress until he made his announcement at the Worldwide Cooperative of Nations. After that, once they saw his terrifying futuristic arsenal, it became clear that opposing him would be unwise. Few knew about his status as a Hero at the time, or about the existence of demons and angels, so they weren't sure just how dangerous he was. And since you probably weren't even born yet, it doesn't surprise me that you don't know any of this. Even if you were, the general public was never privy to this information."

Clarence cocked an eyebrow as the two of them jumped into the air and began to fly, Marie leading the way with her internal map taking them to London. "Hero? What is that? How do you know this stuff? You must have been a fairly important government figure, to say the least."

"That is one way of looking at it. I know a great many secrets, Clarence. As I said before, I make it my business to learn things others don't know. It's what I do."

The two of them flew into a patch of fog and slowed their speed down, just in case an unexpected airbus came flying through and smashed into them. "I don't suppose you'll ever give me details, then?"

"Not ever. You're not that special, dear." Marie winked at him as she glanced up through the fog at the sun in the sky. "It's about midday. At this rate, we'll be in London before 10 PM. The cover of darkness will allow me to sneak around unseen."

"What are you going to do there, anyway?" Clarence frowned at her backside, though she couldn't see his face given she was flying in the lead. "We're going to stick out like sore thumbs, not to mention we glow in the dark somewhat. Being sneaky seems pretty impossible."

"I have some contacts in the city. I'm going to get in touch with them and work on the first part of my plan. What's really great though is that your megachurch is in London too, so we can kill two birds with one stone."

"What do you mean by that? You gonna let me in on this plan of yours?"

"It's more fun if I keep it a surprise." Marie snickered quietly to herself. Oh the genius of her master plan... it was all going to work out so well in the end.

Clarence grumbled quietly to himself. "Pff, fine. Don't tell me, then. Like I care."

Several hours passed as the two of them continued flying at ridiculous speeds towards their intended destination. As expected, the always punctual Marie arrived a mile away from the outskirts of the London Wall just a few minutes before 10 PM, and the two of them landed in a small section of trees some distance away.

"I'm going in alone for now, Clarence. You stay here, out of sight. You don't have the stealth training that I do, so your clumsy movement will ensure we're seen. I can't have that, since the situation I'm returning to will be... delicate. Especially given my new form."

Suspicion had been growing in the back of his mind for a while now, but Clarence had finally had enough. "Marie, I have an important question to ask. I want the answer straight, understand? No subterfuge."

Marie exhaled more quietly than usual as she turned to stare at the man behind her. "You're not usually so serious. Go on, then." She crossed her arms and groaned inwardly. *Perhaps the worm has finally put two and two together.*

"Are you an ally of the demons?" Clarence stared into her eyes intently for once, the serious expression on his face not wavering as he searched for clues about the truth.

Marie didn't keep him waiting. "Yes. I work for the demons, Clarence. I am neither allied with the angels, nor the gods. Does this change anything for you?"

Clarence took a few carefully measured breaths, before his stance became relaxed. "No. I constantly find myself growing to hate the angels more and more, especially Raphael. I greatly want revenge at this point. I'm not... comfortable... with the idea of working with the demons..."

Marie shrugged. "I am the only official human ally the demons have, actually. The demons have always worked from the shadows, and I hardly consider them my best friends. They're the

means to an end, and I don't trust any of them further than I can dropkick them. I'm not asking you to ally with them, only to consider them useful tools, as I do."

Clarence glared at her ever so slightly. "Those goals you just mentioned, what might they be?"

"Oh, that's easy. Killing the angels and gods, of course." Marie let a smile slip through as her own personal thoughts went wild. *Also ruling the universe and knowing all of its secrets. That would be a nice upside, but I'll settle for having some fun. Not that I'd tell the idiot that.*

Clarence's expression relaxed as he slowly pulled away from her gaze and used his wings to slump down onto his back on the ground. "Ahh, I see now. I don't know what caused you to hate the angels and gods so much, but I can't imagine it was pretty. I'll stay here, then, while you do your thing."

Marie nodded as she turned away to leave. Pausing for a moment, she decided to throw him a bone. "As a matter of fact, I'm going to find a secret cell of demons that are hidden inside of London. I should be back before the morning, but if I'm not back by this same time tomorrow, assume you're on your own. It's not like you need food or anything, so you can wait a few days if you want, but if I come back late and you're not here, I'll understand why."

Clarence smiled as he eyed her from the rear once again. "You act tough, but it seems you might be hiding a soft side, Marie. I'll keep that in mind."

"Idiot." Marie rolled her eyes as she quickly jumped up and flew off into the distance, this time by herself.

Clarence sighed as he lay all by himself now, the silence of the encroaching darkness bearing down on him, only to be held off by the sound of crickets and other wildlife. "Wish I had a book to read or something. This is gonna be so boring."

Marie sneaked carefully outside the walls of London's border, looking closely for the gap that she had heard existed on the south side. Finally, she found it. A small crevasse, widened over the years to be just big enough so that it allowed otherwise unwanted visitors to come and go as they pleased, was split into the wall and dug down into just a bit, with a small bush growing in front of it. Truth be told, Marie could just fly right over the wall with no issue, but the energy detectors would ping her for sure, and even though gaps existed in several places, she had no clue where they were.

This was the most secure way inside.

She folded her wings behind herself tightly, as she squeezed through, her knees scraping across the ground and healing remarkably fast once she had made it through to the other side.

She had always hypothesized that angels would consume their energy to heal minor and major wounds, but experiencing it in a practical setting piqued her interest so much more.

I wonder what the limits are to this body of mine? Marie skulked around a dilapidated old building, one that had been destroyed during the war with the Volgrim ground troops, yet never repaired. It appeared to be an old mini-hotel of some sort, but a massive hole was punched into its second floor and several chunks of the building's side were falling to pieces or crumbling apart at the seams. She gave it another few years at best before the whole thing collapsed into a pile of rubble.

Few people lived in this area, mostly just drifters who didn't have the resources to live in the main city but still wanted to be within the safety of the wall. Living this close to the secret entrance was a death sentence though, if they were ever spotted by demons.

Speaking of which, Marie halted as she rounded a corner and came face to face with a bum pushing a four-wheeled cart along. She actually smelled the whiskey before she saw him, as the stench was quite unbearable.

Their eyes met at the same time and the bum yelped in fright. "Jesus Christ!" Stumbling backwards, he fell on his ass and gaped at her in amazement. "Mother of god! Y-you're... a-an angel!" His jaw hung down as he stared at her in disbelief.

Marie grimaced. She did not wish to be spotted. "Sorry, old man. I hope you're a god-fearing fellow."

"I-I never thought that you were..." He started to say something else, but Marie lunged at him before the old fool could make any more noise, dashing behind him with alarming speed and snapping his neck in the blink of an eye.

"Sorry, old timer. Rest easy now. Your troubles are over." Marie let his body sink down slowly, dragging him quickly inside the hotel that she had wandered past, before she tossed his cart inside. Quickly running around the building, she forcefully shoved several key braces out of position in a way that the building would collapse within the next day or so. By then, she'd be long gone, and they'd probably never find his body.

Breathing calmly, she continued making her way forwards, chancing upon a disgusting old blanket lying out in a field. Deciding it was better than nothing, she tucked her wings in and wrapped it around herself to mute the light emanating from her body. It smelled something fierce, like meat that had molded over the course of several months and had become infected with some horrible virus, but she didn't mind too much. She'd had worse in her youth.

Her youth... Marie felt her expression darken as she quickly made her way around the broken husk of the outer city, searching for the entrance to the sewers. Her life had been so

hard before she was introduced to the concept of learning and books. Perhaps being orphaned at a young age had been what hardened her, allowing her to more easily make difficult decisions that would paralyze weaker beings with indecision. Even so, it was an awful childhood. Dolls and fairies and princesses were not what she had learned of the world from a young age. Humans were nasty, awful beings... always looking out to save their own skin or further their own desires. Nobody cared about the feelings of some runaway brat or an orphan with no home to return to.

She smiled tightly as she thought back to those dark days. *I wouldn't have had it any other way.* The twisting of the knife into her captor's heart, the look of agony on his face as his valuable asset made her great escape. It was all too easy. He had trained her well, perhaps too well. She probably ought to have been grateful to him, or to at least loathe him for what he did to her, but in truth it had been well over a hundred years. She had long since lost her hatred and love for that man.

Marie blinked as she saw the target was within sight. A manhole cover lay placed over the entrance to the sewer that she needed to enter, a mere fifty yards away. Closing her eyes and listening intently, she took note that nobody was nearby who might be able to see her. Given its location in the middle of what plainly used to be a main street in a bustling neighborhood, it couldn't hurt to be careful.

She slipped over to it in the blink of an eye, tossing the blanket behind without a hint of regret, as she yanked the sewer cover up and off in the blink of an eye, making no noise at all as if she had done it hundreds of times before. She tossed the cover up in the air lightly, leapt down into the sewer, and caught the cover before it could smack loudly on top, all in one smooth motion.

God, I'm good.

Marie gave herself a mental pat on the back, as she glanced around once at the bottom to see where she needed to go. Despite it being pitch black inside, she could see around perfectly, as if the place was illuminated by an odd blue glow. All around her, strange colorful lines went this way and that, lighting up the darkness of the cave.

She figured out within a few seconds what those lines were. *It seems that in darkness, angels can see the spiritual lines left behind by demons. This makes it easier to track them in otherwise impossible places. Good to know, I'll have to keep this in mind once I get back.*

Becoming an angel might have just been the best thing that had ever happened to her. Now she knew how they worked from the inside, and could figure out their weaknesses and strengths to a more perfect degree not previously achieved by anyone, human or demon.

Noting that dozens of the lines appeared to go from the manhole, down and to a certain specific direction, Marie quickly followed them.

The minutes dragged on, and she took so many turns right and left that she knew if escape was to become necessary, even her mental map would lose the direction she had come from. Still the lines seemed to be thickening noticeably as they joined from other directions, all converging towards one specific point. *The underground base I've heard so much about.*

Marie blinked in surprise, suddenly realizing she had already arrived. It had taken less time than expected, but this was indeed the door she had been briefed on by Satan a few years back. This is the place the demons exited from to make their assaults on the human city above, and none were the wiser... yet. Truth be told, Jason might just be able to figure it out, if he ever decided to do some serious snooping. That guy was a real pain in the ass.

The door was a fairly normal looking one. If humans were to stumble around the sewers for several hours, they might overlook it. It appeared to be rotted, and had a small slit cut in it, presumably for those who were inside to see who was outside at any given time. It was deathly silent down here, but Marie was able to detect the presence of magic surrounding the whole section the door was attached to, likely in order to render any noise from the inside inert.

She wasted no time. Bracing herself, she pounded on the door. Wham-wham, wham, wham-wham. A five note chorus that should be recognizable to any demon as the code passed down through official channels that was to be used for the month. Had she waited too much longer after her death before coming back to Earth, it might not have been up to date and would have caused suspicion.

Several long moments passed, and Marie began to feel slightly nervous. She was an angel now, of course, and any pure-blooded demon would attack her on sight. Her words might not be able to save her, and she didn't have her technology to protect her like she normally would.

Still, though, when she thought about it, she realized there was little to fear. She had dissected several demons in secret and had studied demonology for decades. Combined with her powerful new form, she should be able to defend herself against even a fearsome horde of- wait, the door was shifting slightly. Somebody was approaching.

A moment later, chills went down her spine as two beady red eyes appeared, both of them jerking open in surprise at the sight of her. "What the hell?! An angel?!"

"Calm down. Follow standard procedure. What is The First Emperor's favorite food?" Marie forced her voice to stay even, as the demon stared back at her with wide eyes.

"I dunno, maybe ye' could tell me, Betrayer." The demon was already ignoring procedure.

Marie's expressionless face contorted into one of anger. "Imbecile, you're supposed to respond properly, no matter who is at the door."

"Yer callin' me names, eh?" The demon suddenly walked away from the door, and the sound-nullifying magic took effect once again. Marie had little doubt as to what would come next.

A moment later, the door was thrown open as several mean looking Scythers and Shadow-walkers could be seen, readying their weapons. The demon at the door was a rather diminutive shadow-walker, but the look on his face made Marie's skin crawl. "Oooh, look at this... a sexy lady angel, all by herself. Always wanted one of you for a *pet*." He raised an eyebrow and licked his lips suggestively as his eyes roved all over her body.

Unfortunately for him, his words only served to piss her off. "For your information, I happen to be a mole that works directly under Satan, but now I'm not letting you off the hook." Her face turned into a deadly expression of calm as she dashed forwards with the power of her wings, raising her feet off the ground and delivering a mighty double-kick directly into the shadow-walker's ribs. He probably would have screamed in pain if he had any breath left in him. The impact from her kick sent him flying straight back, smashing him into the wall and knocking him out cold.

Marie readied herself, as the other demons in the room quickly became enraged and started to move towards her.

"STOP!" A shrill voice bellowed out, and everyone froze at once, as yet another shadow-walker entered from a doorway off to the side. "What the fuck is going on out here?! I'm trying to take a nap, you insolent little shitbags!" The shadow-walker looked much bigger and more intimidating than the rest, but his voice was comically high-pitched, as if his diet consisted entirely of helium and nothing else. It was quite the contrasting set of characteristics. "What happened to Torlok?! Why is an angel standing there?! Why didn't any of you fuck-faces wake me up?!"

"S-sorry, boss..." One of the scythers whimpered softly as he lowered his bladed arms. "Torlok was just, you know, getting ahead of himself. But she's an angel, you know. She's the enemy."

The massive shadow-walker quickly stared over at Marie, sizing her up. "No kidding. Not only is it just one angel that showed up at our door, this bitch would eat you all for breakfast. Haven't any of you morons been paying attention to your threat assessment guidelines?!"

Everyone in the room lowered their weapons slightly and bowed their heads in shame.

Marie eyed the approaching shadow-walker warily. *I like this guy, he's my kind of demon. Nice and plainspoken.* She smiled faintly at him even though in this situation they might just

end up fighting.

"You, lady, who are you? No way an angel would just happen upon this hideout and then knock at the door without being either crazy powerful or recklessly stupid."

Marie's smile widened. "You're smarter than the rest of them. I'm Marie, and I only became an angel very recently. Actually, I used to be a normal human who worked directly under Satan himself."

The shadow-walker's eyes brightened slightly. "Ahh, now that'cha mention it, you do look familiar. My name's Davook, I run the London Assault Entrance. I didn't get this position by being a bumbling idiot either, though I tried not to do any hard work. Actually, I've seen you before. I never forget a pretty face."

"That's touching. I don't know you, but if you know me, it makes both our lives easier. I need to get in touch with Satan. Tell him to come here so I can speak with him."

Davook chuckled. "No can do, sexy. Just 'cause I recognize you doesn't mean I trust you. Also, if you're not who you say you are and I call the big guy down here, he'll tear me to pieces. Not acceptable. I like my head where it's at, thank you very much."

Marie groaned as she stared him down. "Come on, work with me here. I need to get in contact with Satan somehow. Hell, if you give me access to a mental-transmitter, I can get in touch with one of my other contacts. They'll verify my identity."

The strange nasally sounding shadow-walker rocked back and forth on his heels for a moment as he glanced from her to his men and back again. "Haaah, this is a pain in my ass. Get in here, first of all, and stop standing out there in the hallway. I'll let you borrow mine, but I need to tap in to hear what's being said as well. Security reasons."

Marie's smile broadened dramatically. "I like you, Davook. You're a man after my heart. Much smarter than the idiots I've dealt with so far." She stepped inside and swung the door shut behind her quickly, noting with interest that it locked itself and the magical barrier reintegrated after a few moments to seal the door.

"Cheh, no kidding. I'm the brains of this operation. Come on back to my room, and let's get this over with."

"Sure thing. But if you touch me, you're dead."

"Already figured as much." Davook grumbled to himself as the two made their way back to his private quarters.

Part 342a: Reversal

Marie grinned devilishly at herself, or rather, the other 'her' standing a few feet away. "You look like an angel."

"I *am* an angel. But you knew that already." Her other form from this universe smiled back. "Long time no see, sort of. It's only been a day or two, but dying has a way of messing up your internal chronometer."

"More importantly, I guess this proves your theory after all." Human Marie eyeballed her angelic clone up and down. "What does it feel like? Anything noteworthy?"

"A tremendous increase in most human abilities. My vision is improved, my hearing, my strength, speed... my brain doesn't feel any faster, but..."

"...You can't make something any faster when it's already as good as it gets." Human Marie finished Angel Marie's sentence for her, both of them cracking up like little children. "Honestly though, I didn't think you were right, all those years. The fact you can just give energy to the angels and reincarnate once dead means you essentially have a get-out-of-death-free card. The first time, anyway. And not you, I suppose, but more me..."

"Yeah, I already used mine up. If you don't start praying nightly, you won't be able to make use of this ability." Angel Marie glanced around the small room. Thanks to the mental transmitter, she had been able to get in touch with Marie 6F, the designation for her universe that they had arbitrarily settled on. Honestly, the names didn't matter that much, except when talking in a group of three or more.

"Gods don't exist in the universe I come from, so the resurrection project won't benefit me. As long as I stay in this universe they might, but if you're here now, then I need to return to mine." The human Marie reached back and pulled a cup of coffee off the small bedside table behind herself. "If only you'd seen the look on Satan's face when he saw me. He was completely flabbergasted."

"I believe it! Satan is a powerful demon, but thick as they come. It'll take him some time to piece it all together. But... listen... before you return, I need your help with something." The angel paused as she scratched her chin for a moment. "It's with regards to my new form, and a convenient pawn I stumbled across. Simply put, I have a plan to destroy the angels and gods. It might just work so splendidly that we create Jason's future that he's so worried about hundreds of years early. There is, however, a problem..."

The human Marie stared at her carefully. "You're an angel now, so if you kill off the other angels, you might end up dying too?"

"Exactly. I need to know what my limits are, and come up with a way to keep myself alive in the instance that the angels are killed off."

Human Marie snickered slightly. "I could try praying to you every night."

"You're hilarious."

"I know."

The two of them sighed simultaneously, as if they were twins sharing the same mental wavelength. Human Marie broke the silence. "It's good you got in touch with me. I can talk with our other selves and try to formulate a plan. Experiments are going to be needed, and they might hurt quite a bit."

"I expected as much. Tell Satan that if we start fighting angels again to try and take some of them alive. I'd rather experiment on them, since I'm not fond of pain. Purebloods and pseudo-humans both would be ideal, so we can find the subtle differences between them." Angel Marie glanced down at her hands as she paused for a moment. "Oh, hmm. Look at that. I hadn't noticed how smooth my skin was yet. Just when I thought it wasn't possible to look any more beautiful, the universe proves me wrong!"

"You and your humble-bragging. Not that I disagree, it did appear to take ten visible years off. This might even be better than Satan's immortality." Human Marie tapped her lip for a few moments. "Speaking of which, I'm debating whether I should renew the immortality contract with Satan. Do you know if it persisted through your death into your angelic form? Might it even override the negative side-effects of being an angel, as far as dying if you don't take in enough energy?"

"I'm not certain. Just another thing we'll have to test, though I'd wager the contract dissolved after my death." The angel grinned slightly. "At least Jason had the decency to kill me instantly. I barely even felt it happen. It was like I suddenly fell asleep, but woke up several moments later in a blinding white room. No light at the end of a tunnel sadly, but it still felt strangely poetic."

"Sheesh, you B-series Marie's are such romantics. It's one of the few traits I don't share with you."

"But the F-series Marie's can be such grumps! Try and put a little sparkle in your life! It'll make you a far happier woman." Angel Marie groaned melodramatically as she walked towards

the door. "Anyway, I'll be heading back to Earth now. Make sure the imps and such know who I am... we wouldn't want any misunderstandings while I'm coming and going."

"Sure thing. Take care of yourself. Your death had a big ripple effect on the stability of the B cluster. We might need to use the contingency plan if it gets any worse."

Angel Marie slowly closed the door behind herself. "I'll fix it. Just give me some time... I have a plan."

"I know."

Harold teleported me into the hospital, apparently located in the east side of London. It was built after the Volgrim attacks, along with a dozen others around the capital. Since there was such an influx of patients due to debris raining down from space, and the day the Dragoons launched their assault, it was unclear when or if the conflict would ever let up, so the hospitals were built to accommodate a large influx of sick and wounded people, and now they all languished in half-full capacities. At least the jobs for the medical staff weren't especially strenuous, not to mention I had heard about a new prototype robot series that was being used to treat patients remotely. Cool stuff, if I'm being honest.

" Detect. "

I use my wordsmithing to locate Amelia by her energy patterns. Unlike using 'locate', Detect allows me to hunt for any vague pattern or object I might be looking for, and in this case I use it to turn energy around me from invisible to visible. In this way, I can see energy types based on colors, so Amelia is a red dot in a sea of white. Humans are nearly impossible to see, when I use Detect to locate energy readings. In large groups though, I can perceive them well enough that I understand what their energy looks like.

I quickly make my way two floors up from where Harold dropped me off, keeping my pace even so I don't appear alarmed or anything. Truth be told, I'm not sure why Amelia would come to a hospital, given she has no friends that I know of.

I walk past the maternity ward, noting with interest that she isn't in there. I had almost thought she might be visiting the infants or something, since I've been giving her their energy for a while now.

I walk down the hallways, disabling Detect as I walk into the room where she's... what the heck? She's wearing a nurse uniform for some reason.

Somehow she senses me walk in the room and quickly whirls to put her finger on her lips. "Shh. He's very tired."

No hello or anything. Guess she knew I was coming? I walk forwards and spot an elderly man sleeping in a bed, a few drops of blood visible on the bib the nurses had tucked into the neckline of his shirt. He must have had a nosebleed or something.

I quietly walk over and kneel down beside her. "Amelia, what are you up to?"

She cocks an eyebrow at my words. "Isn't it obvious? I'm helping people." As she says this, I notice her hand is lightly gripping the man's arm and I can feel a stream of energy leaving her body and entering his.

"You're... healing him?"

My words must have been filled with disbelief, because she rolls her eyes at me. "No, I'm killing him. Obviously. Are you just here to check up on me?"

I shrug and blush slightly, feeling embarrassed for doubting her. "Err, I just wanted to talk with you... and Harold said you were down here. I didn't mean to be rude or anything. Actually, this is pretty great."

Amelia smiles cheerfully, though she still keeps her voice quiet. "Yep! I realized that sitting around doing nothing all day was a waste, so I decided to go to Earth and help people out. I'm going to start healing patients with chronic diseases or those having major medical emergencies. I've already started making a name for myself, and I've only been doing it a day!"

"Yeah, I bet." I snicker, thinking to myself that most doctors would kill to have her powers.

"You should help me." Amelia quickly turns back to the old man, averting her eyes from mine. "Killing is bad, you know. You should try healing people, for once. Saving a life... it feels a lot better than taking one."

Her tone is almost accusatory and both of our smiles vanish in an instant. "I... well, come on... that's not fair, Amelia. The demons won't sit idly by while I use my powers to heal people. The number of people they can injure or kill far exceeds the numbers I can heal by myself."

"You have clones, Jason. Way more than half of them do nothing all day. They should be on the surface, helping people and improving lives. Haven't you looked around, lately?" Amelia's voice is getting softer, and I can hear her voice crack slightly. "People are miserable, Jason. Despite all the advances in technology, we still use money for currency even though you could make unlimited power a reality. People should be able to use replicators for all their needs, but they can't. The system feels rigged, to them."

"How do you know this?" The instant I ask the question, I mentally smack myself in the head. It's obvious how she knows it.

She tells me anyway. "I've been talking to people, Jason. This man here... his name is Jeremy. He's one of the people who didn't accept the nanobot injections, so he's reaching the end of his lifespan. His wife already died, and his children and grandchildren were killed by the Volgrim. People like him are aching for change, Jason. *Real* change."

I nod as I bow my head. "Yeah, I know. You're right. Sorry." I sigh to myself as I lift my head to stare up at the ceiling. My clones, huh? She's absolutely right. I haven't spoken to the 'little people' in so long... she almost went to tears because of the woman who died, but I didn't feel anything. It's like... I'm fighting for humanity, but I feel no real attachment to them. I'm basically just doing it because I have to.

She's also right about myself and the violence I live by. Violence is so nonchalant these days. I killed Marie and felt slightly guilty about it, but deep down I was relieved that she died. I was relieved that trillions of Volgrim were killed, and I was relieved the nuclear bomb went off and killed millions of demons without a hitch.

I'm always so happy about killing, yet Amelia, the 'evil' person I remember from the future, is secretly so pure-hearted and innocent. She's down here, giving it all she's got to heal old men like this guy... men who will die in a few years anyway, while I'm putting all my energy into ending lives prematurely.

"You've got a point, Amelia. All right, I'll send ten thousand clones to the surface. There are still many clones at the JIB who can play offense, defense, or support. My clones are intelligent, they'll think of stuff to improve life for all of humanity. We'll make it work."

Her face brightens up as I lower my head to find her staring up at me with a smile on her face. "That's good, Jason. Honestly though, it's not so much about just the act of improving lives, but that *you* try to help some people personally for once, you know? It would be good for you. Killing all the time will corrupt your soul."

I'm getting lectured by a woman who has a freaking evil black dragon inside her body. Worse, I feel like I deserve the lecture.

"Fine, I'll help some folks too."

I start to stand up to leave but she quickly grabs my wrist. "Jason, don't be like that. Come on, this isn't a punishment. Don't do this begrudgingly just because you feel like I'm ordering you around... do it because you want to. You're a good person, Jason, you just need to prove that to yourself now."

I rest my hand on hers for a moment, before pulling her hand off my wrist tenderly. "I will. Thank you, Amelia. It means a lot to me that you care so much."

A moment later, I teleport away. I was wrong to doubt Amelia. She's put her faith in me, so I should have faith in her. I should prove her right, and start applying myself to better things...

...but, honestly... the demons still need to die.

Part 343a:

Clarence tapped his foot impatiently as he glanced up at the midday sun. It had already been close to 18 hours now, and the day was slowly going to morph into night-time. She wasn't back yet...

What to do... what to do... Clarence rubbed his eyes with his fingers as he groaned quietly. "I hope nothing happened to her."

He opened his eyes and continued to stare at the London's outer wall, just over a mile away. What was her plan, anyway? She made it sound like she was some super-genius who was going to destroy all the angels and gods in one fell swoop... and she was allied with the demons too. The demons were evil, or at least he had preached they were, for a long time now. But then, if they were evil, then allying with them would make him evil too. Aha, that couldn't be the case, for Clarence was a good man. Greedy, yes... willing to sell himself out for money, yes... but not evil!

And if he wasn't evil, then naturally it stood to reason that the demons couldn't be evil. Or, at least, they were no more evil than the angels were. It wasn't a demon that stabbed him to death, or manipulated him for its own favor... an angel did that, and an Archangel to boot!

Right, so that means fighting the angels and gods is just. They need to be punished for their crimes against humanity.

Clarence smiled slightly to himself. Assuming Marie returned, the two of them would embark on a quest to destroy the gods. It was alright, as they needed to face the wrath of humanity for their crimes against it.

"Oh, why hello there." A female voice suddenly spoke up from his side and Clarence quickly tensed up and turned to face who had spoken.

An incredibly unbelievably sexy woman stood a few dozen feet away, wearing a ridiculously skimpy tight-fitting outfit that even a man of god like himself could hardly call appropriate attire for BDSM play. This woman... was definitely not Marie. *Why the hell is she wearing that in the middle of the day?!*

Clarence's cheeks turned red hot and he averted his eyes. "Jesus Christ, lady! D-don't sneak up on a man like that! Where are your clothes?!"

"Huh? I am wearing clothes. More importantly, what's a false angel doing standing outside the City of London?" Her sultry voice made his heart quiver for a moment before he managed to

get control of himself to turn and face her again.

When he looked at her more closely, without allowing his eyes to be drawn to the weird straps that barely covered her chest and the thin pieces of fabric that hardly covered her lower bits, he took a step back in alarm, noting her aura color was not the same as the humans he had seen over in Les Houches. She clearly wasn't an angel either, meaning...

"You're a demon?"

She gave him a look of disbelief before replying. "Obviously. I'm also a woman and you're a man. Anything else you'd like to get out of the way? I mean, given you're a mortal enemy of the demons, I should be ripping you to shreds right now but I'm rather bored. Be glad I've let you speak this long."

Clarence quickly crossed his arms as he felt his fingers beginning to twitch in fear. This woman, she wasn't a weak demon... she appeared to be extremely confident of her odds of winning, though Clarence was pretty sure that any normal demon could beat him right now. He was a bit of a coward and not one to fight unless he absolutely had to.

"Err, thank you for that. I guess. I'm Clarence, and actually I don't believe we are enemies." He felt his eyes wavering as her shockingly attractive body screamed at him to look, but he kept forcing himself to look into her eyes. Somehow her eyes were even sexier than the rest of her body, as if she was casting a bewitching spell on him.

"Mmm. I find that hard to believe, but I'll play along. You're no threat to me anyway. I'm Belial, second Emperor of Hell. Be thankful for my generosity towards your life."

"Hahaha! This angel says he's an ally?! What a bunch of tomfoolery!" A voice suddenly rang out from all around them and Clarence took a second to realize it was being mentally transmitted into his mind. That was when he noticed an odd black orb she held at her side, its darkness absorbing all of the light around it. It held quite the intimidating presence inside, but the person speaking was rather unintimidating by himself, as his voice rasped like a chain smoker's.

Best to not judge a book by its cover.

"I'm an ally, yes. I have a friend named Marie, she's gone off to speak with the demons about how we can kill all of the angels. I'm not even sure if it's doable."

"Oh? Marie? That name sounds... familiar." Belial reached up and tapped her lip for a moment, Clarence finding himself grateful that she also happened to cover up the smallest bits of her upper body. He secretly wished her long black hair could be brought forwards too, if only to aid in the shielding of his eyes. "Ah, now I remember. She's that sniveling human that always

hangs around my master. She's a conniving witch who seeks to further her own ambitions... can't say I'm fond of her in the slightest."

Clarence swallowed as he edged one of his feet slightly backwards. "O-oh, you're not allies then?"

"I didn't say that. Technically, we exist on the same side, I just can't say that I really trust her at all. I feel that she is an opportunist, always looking for a fresh back to stick a knife in. Still, this idea of killing all the angels does sound appealing..." Belial leaned against a tree as she put her hands on her hips nonchalantly. "How did you get involved with a rogue like her, anyway?"

Clarence took her body language as a hint and eased himself back up against a tree as well. Best to keep this discussion casual, if at all possible. She could clearly tear him to pieces if she wanted.

Clarence took a few minutes at length to explain the situation, and Belial nodded along thoughtfully. As Clarence finished explaining, that odd voice spoke up from the orb again.

"Ridiculous. How could Marie have been reborn as an angel? She's an ally of the demons. Unless..."

Belial raised her hand slightly and aimed it at the orb. "Quiet down, I'm thinking." She poked herself in her belly button as her eyes lingered on the ground for a few moments, thoughts milling about in her head. "Hmm. Perhaps she gave energy to the angels in case she were to die, so she could be resurrected as an angel after death. Smart. I doubt Marie would ally with the angels, if only because her hatred for them seems quite genuine to me. A woman can tell when another woman is lying."

"Cheh, guess that means you never trust any female. I certainly wouldn't. They're all liars." The voice from the orb snickered to himself as Belial shot him a hot glare.

"Valac, you're testing my patience, and insulting me to boot. Come to think of it, I've always wondered what would happen if I used all my might to crush this orb into dust."

The quiet laughter ceased instantly as Clarence perceived a worried expression on a demonic looking face appear in his mind. "You wouldn't."

"Don't test me. Mockery will make your pitiful existence come to a quick end."

"Yes ma'am." The orb, apparently named Valac, quickly shut up.

"Anyway..." Clarence decided to get a word in after the two of them had stopped bickering. "I've explained what I'm doing here. What about you?"

The demon instantly shot him an icy glare. "Don't be presumptuous. I owe you no explanation. I'm just here looking for... a friend." Her expression softened and her glare

dissipated as she glanced back over at the city. "Just a friend."

Clarence's brain yelled at him not to pry, but he had already died once so he was feeling lucky. "A friend? Who?"

"Nobody special. Just a human I met once, several years ago. An interesting fellow. I had some questions to ask him, but even I dare not carelessly wander into the heart of humanity's defenses. Their scanners would pick me up in an instant."

"Ah, so you were just wandering around, looking for a way in?"

She shook her head slowly. "I don't know, to be honest. After seeing the damage he did recently... I just wanted to speak to him. It's probably for the best that we don't speak, after all."

Her voice and gaze were distant as she stared off at the city blankly. Clarence followed her eyes and smiled. "I used to live there, before the Archangel killed me. I was a preacher actually... I ran the Church of Retribution. Millions of people looked up to me... It was a good life, though I was an empty man."

"Empty, hmm? Sounds like you were living the life of a rockstar to me!" Valac spoke up again, the mood from earlier gone and his weird confidence having returned. "I bet women were just throwing themselves at your feet!"

"I won't deny they were, but after a while that lifestyle no longer suited me. In a way, becoming an angel has allowed me to see just how deep my human flaws were. They're still there, of course, but now I prioritize fixing them."

Belial sighed. "This has been an interesting conversation. In any case, whether you're an ally or not, I'm too bored to kill you so I'll leave you as you are. On the off chance you do somehow kill all the angels and gods off, I'll thank you now on behalf of Satan. That man dwells on the past too much... having them all die off would greatly benefit his psyche."

"Well, I'm definitely not doing this as a favor for Satan, of all beings... but I'll accept the thanks anyway. Want to stick around? Marie will be back eventually... I hope."

"Pass. I can't stand the woman. Wish I could forget she even exists, to be honest." Belial waved her hand at him as she turned away slowly. "Also, I'm impressed you managed to control your manly urges so well. Most men can't resist my Succubus aura. You have an iron will, one that could prove to be formidable if you trained it carefully."

"Thanks, I guess." Clarence averted his eyes as she turned her backside to him while walking away. "Is it really necessary to wear so few clothes, though?"

"Of course not, but I'm comfortable with my sexuality. If anything, you should learn to embrace your own. Your life would be dramatically improved as a result. Take care, Clarence..."

we'll be seeing each other again, I'm sure." Belial yawned as she strode away from the pseudo-angel.

Minutes passed and soon she was out of sight. Clarence scratched his head. "What a strange woman. She certainly didn't feel evil though, just scary. Maybe demons really aren't that bad."

"They're not." A female voice made him jump as he quickly turned and looked behind himself.

"Marie! That's the second time I've been startled today. Did you succeed?"

"Mmm. I got in contact with the person I needed to. It seems while I was gone, you had a nice chat with Satan's whore. Can't say I like her, but she's definitely a strong-willed female. I can respect that much about her."

Marie didn't wait for a response as she turned back towards London and began walking quickly. Clarence quickly stumbled forwards and fell into line beside her. "What's your plan, then?"

If Marie noticed the change of subject, she didn't seem to care in the slightest. "You're a preacher who holds sway over millions of people that worship the gods. Their prayer energy keeps the gods alive. Do the math."

Clarence blinked twice as he thought about it. "So... we're going to tell people to stop worshipping the gods? I guess that could work. Without the energy to go on, they will probably die off. How long will that take though?"

"You haven't thought this through as much as I thought you would. Given I was gone nearly a whole day, I expected you to dwell more deeply on your upcoming role in their deaths." Marie chided him angrily and he flinched at her mild barrage. "Put more effort into your brain, Clarence. The gods have stockpiled enough energy that if they merely cull the pseudo-angels and live off what's remaining of the energy stockpiles, they will live for tens of millions of years more. And that's if they keep the few thousand remaining pureblood angels alive. If they kill them off too, then it could be far longer than that. No... we won't be simply draining their energy and taking it from them. We're going to steal it for ourselves."

Clarence cocked an eyebrow. "I beg your pardon... but how are we going to do that? And why?"

"You have to think long-term, Clarence. If we kill off the angels somehow, or we alert them to our presence, the automatic infusion of energy that every angel and pseudo-angel is getting right now will be cut off, and we will die very quickly. By the estimations my acquaintance made, I would perish within two weeks." Marie paused her walking and tapped her wrist. "The

gods and archangels devised the automatic resurrection system, but also the system that divvies out energy to all angels and pseudo-angels so they don't die. Pseudo angels get very little compared to the others, so if cut off from the main supply, we would evaporate in a matter of days."

"Makes sense." Clarence scratched his head thoughtfully. "So how do we steal the energy?"

The woman groaned. "You really are thick. It's easy, we'll just get the humans to pray to *me*. You'll convince them that the gods are false gods, and that I am literally Saint Marie. Give them an image of my likeness so I won't be confused with any possible other Marie's up in Heaven, and the energy will go to me."

Clarence instantly frowned. "Why you? Why should I tell them to pray to you? I mean, no offense, but I don't particularly trust you."

"Simple. Nobody will believe you if you tell them it's you, because that will look self-serving. In fact, I estimate at best only half of the congregation will pray to me anyway, even if you give it your all. But that's still a million or more that are giving us solely the energy, and it won't be going to the gods. Over time, we might be able to increase that number."

"Do you even know if this will work? Who says the energy can be diverted to you?"

For once, Marie seemed to enjoy the questioning. It was as if she was proud he was using his brain. "There's a lot to unpack for my plan, but it should work. Think of the prayer energy transfer like a patent system. Most people pray to Jesus Christ, or 'our god who art in heaven'. The gods have taken many different names across thousands of religions over the millennia, so any contemporary figure someone prays to will generally be one god or another in Heaven. However, I essentially have patented myself. If people pray to my name with my face in their mind, I will instead receive the energy. The gods can't take my patent, because I'm still alive. If they can kill me, then they will be able to retake that energy and redirect the prayers back to themselves. I don't plan on dying though, so that won't be an issue."

"Do I have any reason to believe you'll give me some of the energy you receive?" Clarence felt suspicion burning in his chest. This deal was simply too good to be true. If what Belial had said was right, Marie could be quite a convincing liar.

"You have good reason to suspect me, but I won't betray you. The opportunity to destroy the gods has eluded me for my entire life, but this is something I can't waste. If this works, then unlike the gods, I won't have the handicap of having to give energy to millions of other angels, just you and me. Even if only half of the current believers begin praying to me, we will quickly outpace their energy gains with a millionth the consumption. We may become powerful enough to achieve Cosmic class status. But... that's probably a pipe dream."

Clarence tilted his head up and down very slowly. *She's talking a lot more than usual. Somehow, the more she talks, the less I believe her.*

"Alright, I understand. Tell me what to do, and I'll do it. However, I don't think we should rush in there right now. We need to plan our movements first. The city is heavily monitored against anyone with a unique energy signature, and even if we're not outright stopped, we're likely to draw unwanted attention to ourselves. Also, if the plan fails and people don't pray to you, the gods might find out our plan, cut us off, and send a legion of angels to kill us. We can't afford to rush this."

Marie started to say something, but then paused. "Actually, that is a good point. This can't be haphazard... I should get some help first." She shot an odd glance at him, almost as if to say *wow, the idiot has a brain after all*. Clarence chose to interpret the look as a compliment.

"There ya go. That sounds like a plan to me." He smiled, but secretly he worried to himself about what sort of help a snake like Marie could get given her current circumstances. It was probably better that he didn't know, if he was being honest.

Marie grimaced as she stared off at the walls of London. "We'll skip this for now. Let's come back once we've drafted a plan and worked out the kinks. For now, we'll go to where I live and hole up for a while. You'll get to meet some interesting characters there."

"Interesting characters?"

"You know. People like Satan." Marie winked at him as Clarence simply smiled nervously. *Let's hope I allied with the right side.*

Part 344a:

May 20th, 2117.

Jorge pressed his wife against his chest as he gave her a long, solemn hug. After a few moments he separated from her and reached down to hug his daughter as well. Finally, the three of them turned to stare at one another, sadness evident in all their eyes.

"Well... it's almost time. Just ten more minutes to departure."

Jorge spoke softly and Amy nodded vigorously, her eyes filling with tears. "You could stay, you know. You don't have to go."

"Yeah, dad. Someone else can go. You've done enough!" Sarah felt her lip quiver as she quickly looked away to wipe her eyes. "Let some other guy take the lead on this one."

"It just wouldn't feel right, sweetheart. Your mom and I discussed this at length, and we decided that this would be good for us. It will mean that my pay grade rises three ranks, so we'll be able to move to a better district in the capital. Supreme Commander Hiro has one of his clones aboard, so we can set up a magic-based conference call with our family members any time we want. I plan to call every week, so we'll get to talk all the time!"

Jorge's explanation left Sarah wanting. "I guess... I still don't think it's worth it, dad. Our house is plenty big, the neighborhood is a safe one, what more could we want?"

Jorge chuckled. "You're still too young, sweetheart. Someday when you have a family of your own, you'll get it. I'm not being greedy, your mom and I just think we could do better. It'll only be a few years."

Sarah crossed her arms and put on a pouty expression. "It's just not fair. I'll be twenty by the time you're done looking at the stupid planet."

Amy decided to intervene, for Jorge's sake. "You're being selfish, Sarah. We'll talk to your father every single week. He won't miss a single important life event that way. Also, if push comes to shove, an emergency return is always possible. It's really not that big of a deal."

Jorge glanced over at his wife, noting that despite her words, she didn't seem to be convinced it really wasn't 'that big of a deal'. Even she had some reservations.

"Come on, Sarah. You're making your old man feel guilty. You want me to cry myself to sleep every night or something?" Jorge puffed up his lip and blinked as if he was forcing back mock tears, which only made Sarah giggle.

"All right, all right... but you'd better not forget to call! If you're even an hour late I'll wring you out to dry!" Sarah's pouty expression faded and was replaced with a more jovial one, but everyone still felt rather down in the dumps about the whole scenario.

"Officer Gutierrez." A man walked up to the small family and smiled brightly, causing Amy to catch her breath as she looked him in the eyes.

"Supreme Commander?" Jorge stood at attention quickly, as did his wife. Saluting in this context was unnecessary, but in his presence, formality was desirable.

"Not quite. I'm J2-40, one of the Supreme Commander's clones. Specifically, I'll be joining you on your voyage to Revival. I'm not going in a command capacity though, I'm merely there for support reasons. I do hope we'll get to know each other, though."

Jorge nodded and spread a stiff smile across his face. "I feel the same way... sir. Err, what should I call you?"

"Technically my name is the same as the Supreme Commander's, but I am my own person. The other clones call me Hawkeye, so that will do. If you want to keep the relationship formal, Officer Hawkeye is fine by me." The clone of Jason's smiled again as he beckoned towards the ship. "In any case, we're all ready to go when you are."

"I'll be right there, sir." Jorge waved politely as Hawkeye walked away, before turning back to his wife and daughter. "All right. Stay safe, don't have too much fun without me, and make sure to eat your vegetables."

Sarah's smile had dissipated again and tears were in her eyes. Amy likewise was feeling pangs of sadness already, but she managed to keep those hidden. "Love you, dad. Go make history... okay?"

Amy leaned forwards and gave her husband one last kiss and hug, both of them drawing it out for several seconds as their daughter awkwardly shuffled her feet and averted her eyes. Jorge finished and leaned down to hug his daughter one last time, giving her a quick peck on the cheek.

"I'm off. I'll call you once we've hit warp speed."

The women waved goodbye as he quickly walked over to the teleporter pad that had been set up, a faint smile on his face as he returned the wave.

A moment later, he was gone.

Amy and Sarah stared at the pad for several moments, both of them secretly hoping he'd beam back down and declare it was all a mistake.

Sarah finally broke the silence, swallowing hard, as she quickly rubbed her eyes on her shirt's shoulder. "Well, he's gone."

"Yeah." Amy mumbled with less heart than she had intended to, but words escaped her.

"Let's go to church."

"That sounds fine."

The two of them turned and walked away. Now, Jorge's fate would be in the hands of the gods.

"You think I'm ready to start using it in real combat?"

I aim my question at Arthur, and he shrugs.

"I thought you were ready a decade ago. You keep asking me, and my response is always yes. I don't see why you can't just use Excalibur like any normal weapon. In the end, it is just a sword, and you are its master. Stop treating it like some hallowed object reserved only for sacred occasions."

My face stings from his verbal assault, but I keep up a stern expression. I swing my mental image of Excalibur at the massive stone Golem before me, cleaving it in two with little effort, its massive body smashing into the ground with a thunderous crash. The effort taken feels quite negligible.

"I can't tell if I've become more adept at using the sword, or merely better at focusing my mental energy in this dreamworld. Am I swinging the sword harder, or merely perceiving the illusion of the beings that I fight as not truly being there, making the effort required to best them negligible?"

Arthur does a hand-stand, using only his left hand to lift himself up while he swings his own image of Excalibur around wildly, probably as some crazy feat of balance. "It's a mixture of both, I'd assume. You are becoming more adept at using the sword, yes, but your own mastery of mental visualizations is helping too. There is, however, something else at work here."

I wait patiently, but he doesn't elaborate. Apparently he's playing the pronoun game. "What is it?"

"Your inner power levels. They have gone up substantially since when I first met you. Any idea why?"

I shrug. "Maybe I'm like Superman. I'm absorbing the light of the yellow sun."

Arthur shrugs. "I don't know who he is, but that is incorrect. No, but I do believe that you are slowly absorbing some of Excalibur's energy, or perhaps my own. At your current rate of

absorption, of course, it would take you millions of years to reach my level, but it's still an interesting feat."

"Huh." I throw my hands up in the air. "Absorbing spiritual energy, huh? I've killed a lot of demons to date. Do you think if I absorbed their energy when I killed them, it would make me more powerful?"

Arthur drops from his hand-standing position and rolls into a standing position in one smooth movement. The timing was so perfect that I feel envy surge in my veins. "That is an excellent idea. However, short of absorbing Satan himself or some high ranking demon, none of the small fry will do much, if anything for you. Also, there's the matter of their demonic energy versus your heroic energy. It might be similar to swilling Hemlock eagerly. I would advise testing the effects of demonic energy on your body before doing any of that absorbing business."

Arthur's expression is totally neutral, despite the crazy gymnastics he had just been doing. His body is quite durable, and his endurance seems to be almost unlimited. This is what peak performance looks like... he isn't even breathing harder than usual.

"Poison... yeah, you're probably right. Still, what if I managed to defeat Satan and absorb his energy? Think of the energy increase I'd get. And what about his abilities? He has so many... maybe I could take them for myself?"

"Possibly. Then again, do you really need them? Whatever his abilities are, yours should surpass them in every way. You know what they say about coveting the goods another person possesses... it will eat you alive."

Arthur summons a massive fire dragon, the first one he had me fight many years ago when he wanted to test my abilities. I easily cut it down in a matter of seconds, my body moving swift like the wind as I sever its head from its body, then split the head in two with another swing.

A few moments later, I land on the ground and turn back to him. "You're probably right. I can't imagine he was being serious when we last fought, but if he ran away out of fear that would lend credibility to the idea that he was unable to beat me. If he ran because I wasn't a challenge, then that wouldn't make much sense. Still, quite some time has passed. He might have improved, in much the same way as I have."

"Satan is the only being other than Amelia that I genuinely fear. You have spoken about the Volgrim leader, Unarin, before... but he seems to me like a small fry. Satan is a terrible evil, a blight upon this world. I would have once said the same of Amelia, but perhaps you have tamed the beast inside of her. As for Satan though, he not only possesses immense spiritual energy and an arsenal of powers that I can't even comprehend, he is also the leader of billions, possibly

trillions of demons. If he sought to completely overrun the world with demons, he very likely would win in a week."

My mouth feels dry. "If Satan has the capability to wipe out humanity and take over the Earth in one week... why hasn't he?"

"I don't think he can anymore, or perhaps he can but he's not certain of his capabilities. He has faced you in combat, he knows how your Wordsmithing works... and he also knows of your tens of thousands of clones. Killing you isn't enough, since any clone can take your place. Even if he surges his demons onto Earth, you might be able to exterminate them, by literally saying the word 'exterminate'. A single word could spell the end of his entire species. That is a frightening proposition for any leader."

"Yeah... no person wants to be the one in charge when a calamity occurs. They inevitably take the full blame for it." I pause, remembering what happened with Beatrix and how Stonewall used the Christmas Day Massacres against her, blaming her for everything. Some things simply never change...

"Cheh. Tell me about it." Arthur rolls his eyes flippantly. "The peasants of the world simply have no clue how difficult it is to lead a mass of poorly educated people, and worse still, if you educate them, they suddenly think they have all the answers! It makes your job even harder! Truly a lose-lose situation."

"You said it." My thoughts roll back again to Beatrix and how casually the people of the world elected a man who so flippantly stole their rights away. The demagoguery he used turned what could have been an educated populace into a bunch of fearful idiots.

Beatrix... she's living on Mars now, apparently. She long ago renounced her official duties, unable to return in any political form after her humiliating loss to Stonewall. I should speak with her some time.

Several moments pass as Arthur and I stare up at the sun and the clouds passing overhead. He finally speaks up. "How are things going with Amelia?"

"Very well. She's working in a hospital now, using her abilities to heal people. So long as my designated clones give her energy every day, she has zero negative side effects. Also, I took her advice and sent ten thousand clones to Earth to work on improvements for humanity's livelihood. I'm hoping to move away from generic currency towards something more like universal basic income, or away from currency entirely. Replicators can make everything we need, so currency seems pointless."

"Many a king has gone to war and led millions of his men to their deaths, all in pursuit of gold. Truly, money is the work of the demons. Eradicating it from society can only improve the

lives of those no longer bound by its constraints. If nothing else, I support this measure." Arthur chuckles wryly to himself.

"What's so funny?"

He itches under his eye for a moment, a broad grin spreading across his face. "The lost city of El-Dorado. I found it, actually... and I destroyed it. It really was a city of gold. It seems you're bound to follow in my footsteps even in the most menial ways."

"True, that." I glance down at my wrist, only to realize I'm not wearing a watch. It wouldn't work in this world anyway. "Anyway, I need to go. We'll talk again, Arthur."

"Sure thing. Just don't forget me... it can be quite boring in here." Arthur conjured a tasteless apple and bit into it, forcing a lonely smile across his face. "I'll just be sitting here... playing chess by myself."

"You're going to make me throw up with all of this guilt-tripping."

"Good." His smile becomes genuine as I will myself to leave.

The world turns to white as I slowly return back to reality.

Part 345a: Pokerface

"Humans suck. Ah hope they all die." Torlok grumbled as he sat at the same table as a few of the other demons, the four of them playing a game of poker. He curled his lip in disgust as he looked at his hand and the cards on the table. "Call."

The Animus across from him chuckled as he laid a full house on the table. "You lose, moron! You have the worst poker face of anyone here!" Resembling a black-skinned human, his body was tattooed with various images of gruesome torture and violence. His stature was small and lithe, but he was also deceptively strong. More importantly, he was of relatively high intelligence, even among middle-tiered demons.

"Fuck! Fifth time in a row!" Torlok resisted the urge to smash the table as he shoved his pile of bones over to the other demon. These were mock poker chips they used for betting, but they held no inherent value. Poker was merely one way to stymie the boredom of living in an underground sewer base. "You ain't sneakin' cards up yer sleeve, are ya, Smealum?"

"Don't need to, when you're the worst bluffer this side of the portal." Smealum flicked his nose lightly at Torlok, an insulting gesture that generally was used to represent fornicating with goblins... the ugliest of demons.

"Keh... at least I ain't lookin' like my face is 'sposed to be wiped on toilet paper." Torlok tittered to himself as the other demons at the table roared with laughter at their friendly banter, though Smealum didn't seem to think it was very funny.

After a few moments, Torlok turned to his right. "Yo, Davook. You gonna join us or what? Four demons ain't enough fer a good game o' poker."

Davook, ever the entrepreneurial demon, was grimacing at a small pile of paperwork that sat on the desk in front of him as he read through it carefully. "You doofuses play your stupid games. I've got real work here. Don't you even care about the attacks on our kind?"

Torlok's smile faded away. "Yeah. Like ah said, humans are the worst. They're all so preachy 'n uptight, but in the end they're monsters just like us. Still, ain't much one weak little shadow-walker kin' do about it. Best to just leave it to them demons at the top."

"That kind of thinking won't help us at all. Four nuclear detonations happened in the labyrinth this week. Each time, we were powerless to stop them. We lost billions of good soldiers. If everyone thought like you, we'd all just have to roll over and die."

Davook glanced over at the table of demons playing cards, their smiles and laughter gone now as they all stared vacantly at the bones in front of them.

"Yeah, you're right." Smealum spoke up quietly as he rested his hands on the table, tapping his fingers together thoughtfully. "But like he said, if Satan can't do anything about it, what are we supposed to do? We're just underclass demons. You're the strongest of all of us, Davook, maybe the smartest too... and I doubt even you could go toe-to-toe with one of those suited clones the humans are using. They're just too strong. The nukes are hardly the tip of the iceberg."

Torlok bobbed his head along as he listened. "Can't even hide from 'em. They got those sensors that kin' see us even when we're totally cloaked now. We're just lucky Satan holed us up down in this here sewer."

"Hmm. Indeed." Davook flicked through a casualty report on the most recent detonation. Twenty-five million incinerated in an instant, and the radioactive fallout yield had tripled from the previous attack. The humans were fighting dirty. Sixty million demons had been infected with radioactive particles, something that wouldn't affect the highest ranked demons, given their highly enhanced bodies and upper-level regenerative powers. But the lower demons had no such internal defenses and were wracked with all manner of ailments. "It's a slaughter out there. This isn't even like when we fought the angels. At least we won due to sheer numbers. It was a battle of equals, so to speak. This is completely unfair, like a child with sticks and stones against an adult with a tank."

"Come on, Davook. You should stop reading those reports for a while. They're just depressing you more than you usually are." Smealum reached for the deck of cards and shuffled them absent-mindedly, dealing out five cards to himself and the other three demons at the table. "Sometimes you just need to give it a rest. Take it easy."

"Yeah. You're probably right." Davook set the paper on the table gently as he swept his gaze around the fairly sizable room. A hallway down the back led to their living quarters, while his own room was right off to the side for quick access in case of emergencies. This main room was set up somewhat like a bar, with a big whiteboard for whenever they needed to plan an attack or discuss intelligence given by the demons in command. "Fine, deal me in." Davook sighed as he stood up and sauntered around his desk over to where the other demons sat, pulling a chair out as he eased himself up to a corner, Smealum moving over to make room.

"Now we're talkin'! This gonna be a real good game now!" Torlok grinned widely as Smealum dealt five cards to Davook. "No cheatin' though! I got sharp eyes that even a sneaky shithead like you can't fool!"

"Heh, we'll see about that." Davook smiled and felt his body freeze. Something... something had shifted.

He flicked his eyes around the room. There was a sudden feeling of emptiness in the air, though the others hadn't perceived it yet. It was... it was as if...

Davook quickly stood up, the cards falling from his hand onto the table. Torlok snickered. "Cold feet already?"

"Shut up. I can't sense any energy to the northwest. It might be an anti-magic bubble."

Everyone in the room noted the alarm on his face, as they all quickly stood up. "Humans?" Smealum tried to force a smile but it didn't quite connect. "Th-they can't find us here. We're hidden very well."

"That's not true. Satan warned us that their Supreme Commander has ways of locating anything, if he just knows it exists." Davook blanched as the sensation of emptiness seemed to be moving towards them. "Everyone get to the portal in the back and escape through it. Shut it off until you receive my signal. If you don't receive my signal in five minutes, activate the kill code. Destroy the portal."

"Y-you serious? Alright, boss." Torlok quickly beckoned at the other demons as they all quickly and efficiently made their way to the back. "I'll stay with you, boss. Can't have you hold 'em off alone." Despite his cool and collected words, his voice was laced with fear.

"I can handle them alone. Stay safe, Torlok. You and the others leave." Davook reached to his neck and removed a small pendant, handing it over to the younger demon. "If this light goes out, I'm dead. Whether it does or doesn't, you must continue to destroy the portal in five minutes. You know the drill."

Torlok swallowed as he felt his claws shaking. He reached over and took the small red gem from his boss. "You don't have to stay, boss. You kin' come with us..."

"I can't. If I'm wrong..." Davook felt his heart tremble as the bubble started moving even more quickly towards them. "...never mind, I'm not wrong. Get out of here, dipshit. You're slowing me down."

"Alright, boss." Torlok squeezed his black eyes shut for a moment as emotion overtook him. He quickly straightened himself up and rushed towards the back room, slamming the door behind himself without a second word.

Davook tensed up as he jumped over his desk and yanked a small device out, a single button visible on its surface. "I ain't lettin' them take me alive."

He quickly jumped back over, feeling the bubble was now appearing inside the barrier. *They must be right outside the door. Only moments left.*

Quickly, he lifted a couch with his huge muscles and propped it up to shield himself from the main entrance. That was when he heard a faint noise from outside.

A moment later, the door blasted off its hinges as a massive explosion surged inside the room, fire drenching everything in sight. Davook screamed a silent scream as the air was sucked from his body. Losing his focus, he dropped the couch and it slammed into the ground with a deep *thud*. A moment later, he fell to his knees as he wheezed and gasped. *Fuckers. Knew they'd fight dirty.*

At that moment, several suited humans burst into the room, wading through the inferno at the front door as if it didn't even exist. Davook felt incredible pain in his body as the anti-magic bubble swept over him, draining all the power in his body in an instant. He fell to the ground as all his strength vanished, as if the gravity in the room had increased a hundred-fold.

"Hostile sighted! Device is in hand!" One of the suited humans quickly tilted his helmet towards Davook, his hand still weakly clutching the button. He tried with all his might to press it, but his body wouldn't respond to his thoughts.

I was careless. Davook felt his eyes droop as he waited for the end to come. One of the white-suited humans quickly ran over to him, snatching the device from his hands.

"Not so fast, demon. Seems you're all alone here. One last stand, eh?"

Another human yelled in alarm. "My scanner picked up a massive bomb in the ceiling!"

"Don't worry about it. I bet this is the transmitter right here. He thought he'd catch us in a trap, but it ain't happening today." The human laughed viciously as Davook felt the life leaving his body.

No... oxygen... can't breathe... Davook felt a smile creep across his lips. Even if he couldn't kill the humans, he would die anyway. No intel could be extracted from him, and the fire was already burning up the demon's documents. Humans were so... foolish.

The human nearest him leaned down, his voice tinged with glee. "Bet you think we're gonna let you die, eh, *monster*? You ain't so lucky. Your nightmare has only just begun."

Bastards. The world faded away as a single tear made its way down Davook's cheek.

Satan nodded to himself as he appeared to receive a mental communication. Marie watched him with feigned disinterest from a distance as he bobbed his head several times. Then, as if the line had been cut, he turned abruptly to face her. "The humans found our base in London. I was just informed by one of the espers in that district."

"Yet another loss. We seem to be suffering a lot of casualties as of late." Marie fanned her fingers out as she glanced down at her nails. She seemed to be unmoved by their deaths, which made Satan's temper flare up.

"I thought you had this under control months ago. You spoke of technology that would allow us to fight on even footing with the humans, yet the energy weapon defensive matrix technology you gave us isn't enough! We don't have enough of the devices to protect our troops, and even if we did, the nukes are wiping us out in ways we can't defend against!"

"Quite the conundrum." She flicked her eyes over towards him. "It's not my problem though. I didn't promise you anything, the other Marie did. Anyway, I'm working on ways we can fight back. You just have to give me time... quite the interesting development happened recently and I'm working out how to turn it to our advantage."

Satan's anger dissolved slightly as he eyed her coldly. "Development? Explain."

She sighed dramatically as she leaned back against the wall and held eye contact with him.

One interesting fact about this mere human was how little she appeared to fear him. Was it false courage, or did she have a way to neutralize him? He just couldn't be sure.

"Well, I didn't really intend to tell you about it for a while until I had the kinks ironed out... but now's as good a time as any. As it happens, the Marie you know did not die. In fact, she was reincarnated as an angel after death and she managed to escape Heaven."

Satan blinked twice before his face contorted into one of rage. "What?! When did you plan to inform me of this?!"

Marie grimaced at his burst of anger. "Calm down, you obstreperous loudmouth. I intended to tell you eventually. What's more important isn't that she is alive and well, but the contact she met in Heaven and she helped flee from that prison. He will be key to destroying the angels and gods."

Satan calmed down slightly, despite the insult she fired at him, as she always tended to do. Honestly, he wasn't sure why he allowed such insolence, but she *was* the most interesting human he knew. "Who is he?"

"His name is Clarence, and he used to be the leader of the Church of Retribution. His personality was the driving force behind its resurgence, and the reason the angels have become so powerful as of late." Marie paused dramatically as she winked at him. "And now he's dead. The archangel Raphael killed him."

Satan chuckled. "As it turns out, I know him. I recommended him to Zeus and Gabriel as a way to regain their power. His preaching has done them a great service, and me as well."

For once, Marie was the one to be stunned. "What? You recommended him? Why?"

"Come now, that should be obvious. It's a matter of self-preservation. I hate the gods and the gods hate me... but neither one of us can kill each other right now, and if one of us is killed off by the humans, the other will fall next. It's in our own self-interest to maintain the balance of power we used to have in the old days. I'd rather have them remain a threat to the humans and be able to unite with us against humanity if push came to shove."

"That seems... illogical. The gods will never be able to fight humanity. They will never ally with you, either. Their power is merely an addition to the threat leveled against you. Again, as I said, I have a plan to kill them off, so you had better listen." Marie thought back to what he had said about having the gods boost up the Church. It might have seemed smart to him at the time, but she couldn't see why. He truly was an idiot. "At least by boosting up the church, you've made my plan very likely to succeed."

Satan seemed too annoyed by her constant questioning of his abilities to argue about it, so he simply shrugged as he rolled his eyes. "Fine. Tell me about this plan of yours."

Part 346a: Artist

The group of fifty lower-ranked demons stood around in the receiving room, staring at the ground and kicking pebbles absentmindedly. One demon was a noteworthy exception though, as he was blubbering and sobbing incoherently as he clutched a small necklace in one of his hands, the pendant part of it softly pulsing red over and over.

"It's not fair! Why did he hafta stay behind?! Davook was our leader!" Torlok's upper lip trembled as he sobbed violently, the other demons trying to console him but doing a poor job. Honestly, given his normally intimidating shadowy aura created due to his shadow-walker evolution, it was an odd contrast to see him crying like this.

"It's not your fault, Torlok. The boss did what he had to do. He's gone now. We have to move on." Smealum scratched his cheek as he stared down at the inconsolable demon sitting on a tiny stool. "You can't let his death get to you."

"He ain't dead though!" Torlok quickly jerked his head up, tears and snot dripping down his face from all his orifices. It made several demons take a step back in disgust, as they generally weren't used to dealing with such strong emotions. "Look! He left his glowy jewel thing with me! As long as it glows red, he's alive!"

He held the pendant up in the air and Smealum raised an eyebrow in disbelief. "How can that little thing know he's alive? It doesn't make any sense."

"I dunno... I ain't smart like the boss was..." Torlok lowered his hand back down and stared at it as he wiped his eyes again.

"It's probably some kind o' heart monitor. Yeap, the humans have used 'em in covert operations, yessir. When the soldier dies, command knows instantly." One of the nearby goblins spoke up, his voice way too chipper for this time of the day and all the sadness evident around him. "I'd bet my broodmother's next batch on it, you can take that to the bunker!"

Smealum shrugged. "I guess it might work that way. If it can really detect his life energy or whatever, it must be magic based though. No way it would work through dimensional rifts using human technology."

Torlok stood up quickly, his sadness melting away at a ridiculous speed. "Ya really mean it? The boss is alive?"

"Yeap. Well, maybe. Truth be told I ain't fermiliar 'bout that human tech, and even the magical stuff's above my rank. Us Goblin's ain't got much o' the magical stuff in us, no sir."

Torlok nodded enthusiastically. "Wowie! Th-then that means... we could rescue him!"

Smealum's look of disbelief returned instantly with a vengeance. "No way. Absolutely not. If the humans took him, they probably took him to a facility for interrogation. He's probably locked down better than Satan's asshole. No way we're going to be able to find him, let alone rescue him."

Without really even listening, Torlok nodded enthusiastically. "No no, don't ya see?! We're too weak, but the big boss demons ain't! I'm gonna go ask one right now!"

"Wait, what? Come again?" Smealum started to interject but Torlok was already jerking his head around, looking for one of the arch-demons in the area, or possibly an actual Devil. "A couple ought ta' do it. We just gotta find one or two dumb enough to help us out!"

Smealum sighed as he felt himself breathing a little easier. "Oh, good. Nobody would be stupid enough to do that. You're the only idiot who would actually consider it a possibility."

Smealum had hardly finished speaking when Torlok charged off, leaving the group behind. "I'll be back! Gonna go ask some folks if they wanna help us! Be back in a jiffy!"

The other demons gawked as he strode away. The goblin from earlier snickered to himself as he scratched his chin. "Ain't no way that moron's gonna make it. No sir, he's gonna get the shit kicked out of him when he bothers the wrong devil, or my name ain't Skippy!"

Smealum glanced over at him. "A goblin named Skippy? Who named you?"

The goblin shrugged. "I named myself, kiddo. Named me after my favorite brand of peanut butter! Yum!"

Smealum slowly turned and started walking after Torlok. "I'm surrounded by idiots."

Davook felt his eyes opening, but he didn't recall telling them to do that. *What a dream... that was the deepest sleep I've ever had in my life.*

He blinked slowly, staring ahead in confusion. He appeared to be laying flat on his back, and he couldn't seem to move a muscle. The ceiling above him was brown and dingy, covered in blotchy water-spots from leaks... or something. He tried to lift his head but something kept preventing him from moving.

The memories came flooding back in a rush. A bomb. The humans. An attack.

"Well well, looks like our guest is awake." Davook felt his body tense up and he squinted hard as a bright light suddenly appeared directly above his head. It moved around erratically and it was connected to some long... arm? Yes, it was an arm. An arm holding a flashlight.

"Wha... what... where am I?" Davook spoke up but he couldn't move his mouth properly and his words were somewhat slurred, as if he were being doped with drugs.

"I ask the questions, filth. Welcome to the Peeler. I'm sure the scum among your kind have heard about it." The voice was a male's... very deep and sure of himself, as if he could possibly hold a candle to Davook's might. "Don't bother moving around, you'll just hurt yourself. Well, you can if you want... it'll give me a nice laugh anyway."

"The... Peeler?" Davook searched his memory. He'd heard of it, even joked about it with the other demons, but nobody knew what it really was. Just a story told by crazed demons who had escaped... or been let go. They never spoke normally after their return to the labyrinth. Inevitably they were culled due to their weakness and inability to reintegrate with their kind, plus the possibility they might be spying for the humans.

"I didn't stutter." A massive human loomed over him suddenly, his body built like a Minotaur's. He appeared to be Japanese, but spoke fluent English, as if it was his first language. He wore a simple button-down grey dress shirt and big coke-bottle glasses, as if he were a caricature from a human cartoon series. "What is your name, demon?"

"Like I'd tell you anything." Davook sneered at the massive man. Certainly, he was totally helpless, but he wouldn't let his dignity be taken from him without a fight.

"Cute. I like that spirit. Most demons are too easy, and I've operated on hundreds. You're my first shadow-walker though... I'm curious as to how your physiology differs from my favorite subjects." The massive Asian stepped away, his heavy leather shoes plodding against what sounded like wet pavement. "Not too long ago, we managed to capture an incredibly beautiful succubus female. Her screams still ring in my ears. And once I have a demon down here, nobody bothers me while I do my business. I sell the films for ridiculous amounts of money. People have a real hate-boner for your kind."

The man walked back, holding a photo of a badly mutilated corpse, a smile tugging at the corner of his lips. "Nerissa was such a sweet girl, the way she begged me to stop made me want to unbind her. But I'm a professional, so of course I didn't. I like to go look at her grave sometimes... for fun."

Davook blanched at the horrific image before him, the female demon's head and limbs separated from her torso and tied loosely to a table with blood covering everything. He bit his lip as he fought back a gag reflex that threatened to bubble up and shoot from his mouth. "Y-you're horrible. What kind of monster are you?!"

"Monster? All demons say the same thing, it seems. They can't seem to understand the full story. I'm not a monster for dissecting an animal. I'm not a monster for getting revenge on

behalf of all the humans your kind have killed. I'm a human, and you're all animals that belong in a blender. That's the difference between humans and demons. Irreconcilable differences."

The man walked away again, out of Davook's sight. For a moment, he seemed to sigh contentedly as Davook listened and heard the sound of him gently rubbing the photograph in his hands. "I can only hope you'll give me half the pleasure she did. Novelty is the best I can hope for, these days."

Davook swallowed quietly, making sure the human couldn't hear him. "What... what are you planning?"

"Oh, come now... why spoil the fun? Are you the sort of pest that asks others like you how the movie ends before you watch it? No, probably not... you're all too dim to understand even basic human technology. You rely on manipulating blood for your human sacrifices in order to appease dark gods... the source of your power is truly unfathomable."

Davook scrunched up his face at that comment. "What? We don't do anything like that. Why do you torture and slander my people? Where are you getting these twisted ideas?"

"Twisted ideas? The only twisted thing here is that of the demons and the havoc they wreak upon humanity. The bible foretold your return to Earth thousands of years ago. Judgement Day, Armageddon, the Rapture... call it what you will, but true believers like me have known of your evil's existence long before the general populace. I'm simply here to document it and do as God tells me to do."

Davook stared up at the ceiling blankly. *By the seven Hells, this man is a brainwashed fanatic. I'm doomed.*

"Well, in any case, no reason to sit around chit-chatting. I'm sure more demons will be brought to me eventually, and I've got a dinner date with a lovely Miss Mercer in three hours, so I need to do this quickly. You can tell me everything you know right now, or I can get to work showing you why this place is called The Peeler."

Davook sneered at the human off to his side. "I'm not telling you anything. Already said that. You'll have better luck prying open a can of beans with your bare fingers."

"Mmm. I wouldn't be so sure." The man's feet shifted as he stepped back over to what was likely a desk of some sort, as Davook heard the unmistakable clinking of metal on metal. "Well then, seems you and I are going to be getting intimately acquainted."

He walked back over, holding a small, razor sharp scalpel in his hands. "Ever wondered what it would feel like if the skin was ripped off your body in small patches, followed up by rapid healing and then being ripped off again, over and over?"

Davook forced out a nervous smile. "N-no. Can't say I have."

"That's too bad. You're going to find out, monster. Let's go ahead and play around a bit."

Davook bit his lip hard as the scalpel gently sliced into his triceps. *I won't let this one break me.*

"All of them?" I raise an eyebrow at her statement. "You healed literally everyone in the Northern London Metro area?"

Amelia shrugs as she squishes a stress ball in her hands. She seems to be playing with it like it's some kind of little toy, not like she's stressed out or anything. "Just the people in those three hospitals." She leaned back against the wall outside of her patient's room. "This hospital is for military personnel though, and they always have the worst wounds. It might take longer than usual to heal all the people here."

"It's only been a couple weeks though. This is a crazy speed, Amelia! You should be proud of yourself."

She smiles sincerely. "I am, Jason. I helped a lot of people. But there are more to help, and you still haven't given me clones to help out with the healing."

"Oh. Sorry." I feel my cheeks flare up slightly. "I forgot. I'm having my clones comb over records to try and sort out the mess that Stonewall and Ben left behind, as well as going all over the place downtown to get a feel for the city's temperament. They are all disguised though, none of them look like me. I doubt even you would be able to tell."

Amelia's smile fades away slightly. "Are you disguised?"

The question takes me aback as I feel my feet shift away from her slightly. "What?"

"A disguise. Is that what you really look like? Do you look like you used to when you were thirty, or do you look dramatically different now?"

I frown as I try to figure out what she's getting at. "I've shifted my looks several times, but I always revert back to my original form after the disguise has accomplished its goal."

"Are you sure? How do you determine what you looked like?" Amelia keeps firing questions at me as she pulls away from the wall and searches my face for answers.

"I just go by memory, I guess. I might look a little different but..." I pause as a lightbulb goes off in my head. "Actually, I could just wordsmith 'remember' and I'd remember what I looked like as a youth or at any age and I'd remember it perfectly. Heck I might even be able to..." I paused as I flicked my eyes around the room. "Hmm, I'll need an easel, some paintbrushes, and something to draw on."

Amelia stares at me silently for a moment. "Why don't you just summon that stuff with Wordsmithing?"

I blink in surprise. "Oh, right. Of course."

"You can be super dumb sometimes."

"I know."

I quickly pull her away as we walk into a deserted waiting room, all the other guests gone for now as visiting hours are coming to a close soon. " **Create. Create. Create.** " I mentally imagine a set of watercolor paintbrushes, an easel, and a pad of paper. " **Remember. Learn.** " A few moments later, I can perfectly remember every contour of my face from when I was a youth, and I have instantly mastered the art of painting to a ridiculous degree. "Give me a minute, if you please."

Amelia nods as she and I sit beside each other in two adjacent chairs, the easel and paper in front of me as I begin to move my hands. " **SPEED! Perception!** "

I blink as the world around me slows to a crawl, shutting my eyes for what feels like several minutes but likely was a single millisecond in the outside world. When I open my eyes, my hands begin to move at unthinkable speeds. I don't even know how they're doing it, but it's the most incredible sight I've ever seen. It's like a tornado is forming in front of me, and a picture is emerging from the chaos. Amidst the chaos, I spare a millisecond to glance at Amelia. She was looking downwards when I started, and her head is slowly raising up to look at the perfect image of myself in my teens.

A few seconds later, my hands halt entirely of my own accord, and the most incredible portrait I've ever seen has magically formed before my eyes. It's so photorealistic I almost feel that I'm looking at a reflection of myself in a mirror. I can't help but gawk at how incredible it is, and how in the span of a few real-world seconds I managed to create a masterpiece that even machine digital imaging would be hard pressed to compete with.

After I return myself to normal speeds and time accelerates to meet up with me, Amelia jerks her head back in astonishment. "Did... did you just paint that in like, three seconds?"

"Felt like a minute to me... but yes."

Amelia reaches her hand up and comically closes her gaping mouth as she stares at the image for a few long moments. "I've never seen anything like that before. There was just a sound like a small jet engine, then I noticed a weird blurry movement, and by the time I realized what was going on, the painting had just appeared. Did you really paint this?"

"Mhm. I barely even understand how I did it... but I did it."

Amelia quickly looks from the painting to me, and back to the painting again. "Well, it's close. Your nose was a bit smaller when you were younger, and your cheekbones were less pronounced... plus you have that shaved stubble now."

"I cheat, actually. I just use wordsmithing to get rid of my facial hair every morning. I could remove it permanently but I'd prefer not to. It's not a big deal."

She and I share a moment as we smile at each other. Our time together is interrupted as my ears pick up the sound of several boots slowly making their way down the hall.

I glance over in the direction of the hallway and Amelia follows my gaze, as several men in military uniforms slowly amble from the inside of the building towards the exit, laughing and talking with one another.

"It was ruthless, my man! He was scared shitless!"

"We put the fear of god in him. All for the better though, they need to be reminded what fear is about." The bigger man in front chuckles to himself as the other men keep their own laughter muted.

They start to walk past us, but one of the men halts as he glances at me for a moment. "Hey, ain't you the Supreme Commander?"

I stand up and smile at him. "That's correct, soldier. Jason Hiro. You've got good eyes."

He quickly jerks his hand up and salutes me awkwardly. "A pleasure having you in charge, sir! I'm Bubba, and this is Squid on my left and Tomahawk on my right."

I almost want to ask him why they're using their military nicknames, but I shrug it off. They're probably super used to those names by now. "Pleasure to meet you guys. I'm just here with my fiancée." I beckon down at Amelia and she quickly stands and smiles at them. All three of the guys go comically red in the face.

"Shucks, it's true what they say about powerful men. They always got a powerful woman hiding in the shadows! A pleasure to meet ya, miss!"

All three men smile at her jovially as they turn to me. Bubba's the one who decides to tell me all about his day. "We just got back from a surgical strike. We took out a demon base right here underneath the city, then we secured the perimeter!"

"Yeah, but all we got for it was one lousy shadow-walker. Slim pickings." Squid rolls his eyes as his smile is replaced with a grimace. "The rest of the bastards escaped through their portal and severed the link. Almost caught us in a bomb after all of that."

I nod at them. "I heard about the operation. You guys did a good job. Actually, weren't you guys wearing those Hypersuits? I thought we brought them back?"

"You did, and we were." Squid smiles again, and I notice he has a shiny gold tooth in his mouth. Seems those haven't gone out of style in the last hundred years. "Saved our asses, too. Fuckin' Old Yeller almost destroyed everything in the office. Hell, we almost lost the shadow-walker too. All their documents got burned so we couldn't figure out what their operations were or what they were planning."

"We shut them down. Good enough for me." Tomahawk chuckles to himself as he slugs Squid in the arm playfully. "Don't beat yourself up over it. He's in the Peeler now. We'll find out about their plans, one way or another."

I cock an eyebrow at that statement. "The Peeler?"

"You don't know?" Bubba shoots me a quizzical glance. "Sheit, I thought the Supreme Commander would know all 'bout that place! It's an interrogation facility for demons. It's how we always get intel on them. That shadow-walker was the highest ranked one we ever captured though. I'm sure he's got all sorts of secrets he's hiding."

Squid glances to me and then to Amelia before nudging Bubba forwards. "All right, we're keeping the man and his lady apart. Let's get a move on, chatty Cathy."

I smile at all three of them as they wave at me and start to walk away. "Thanks for your service, boys. Good men like you help protect the morality of civilization."

Bubba snickers as he walks away. "I like you. You'll make for a fine Supreme Commander."

As the three of them walk away, I turn back to Amelia to see her smile is gone as she stares after those men. "The 'Peeler'. It sounds awful."

"Aw, c'mon. It's just a scary name to intimidate people. You think they slowly peel the skin off people in the same way we take the skin off an orange?"

Amelia's face contorts into an expression of disgust. "That's truly vile, Jason. I certainly hope they don't do anything like that."

"If it makes you feel better, I could have a clone look into it."

"Whatever. Suit yourself." Amelia shrugs as she turns to the side and carefully peels my painting off the easel I put it on. "I'm going to put this in my room. Hope you don't mind."

"Huh? What for?"

Amelia blushes as she looks away from me. "A l-lady has her reasons, Jason. Don't ask questions you don't want the answer to."

I just shrug dumbly at her. "Hey, suit yourself. Hope you enjoy it."

She swallows heavily and I can't help but think her breathing increases in tempo slightly.
"Don't you worry. I will."

Part 347a:

Diablo stared down at the young demons before him as they wrung their hands together and whimpered. The smell of fear was in the air and they seemed greatly afraid of his reaction to their request.

He scratched his ear and sighed. "Look, I am a reasonable devil, understand? It's not that I can't do it... I'm just not interested. I don't care about the life of some small fry."

The small shadow-walker in front of him... Torgrok or something rather... he seemed greatly upset by Diablo's response. "Ahm sorry, mister Diablo, sir... Mah friend is just in trouble, ya know? H-he was our leader! He stayed behind to save our lives! W-we can't just let him be killed!"

"It's not my problem. Sorry, but I'm not sorry." Diablo raised his hand and silenced the younger demon with a groan as he rubbed his forehead. "This Davook guy was, at best, a mid level demon. Even then, I think he was lower than that. Do you understand how many demons have died of late? The humans' Supreme Commander is ripping us to shreds. I just don't have the personnel to handle such a trifling request."

The smaller demons' ears seemed to lower slightly as his face became crestfallen. "I... I understand..."

Diablo pinched his nose in disgust as he glanced around the hallway around them. Behind himself, the corridor opened into a massive chasm, caused by the detonation of a nuclear weapon only an hour previously. He had only just managed to clean up the radiation in this area when these idiots came to bug him about such a silly request.

"Look, if you really want to rescue him, go do it yourselves. If you fail, you'll have at least tried and you can die with clear consciences. If you succeed, well... that is a great bonus."

Diablo turned away from them and started to walk away, only to nearly run into Bael who had just appeared in the hallway heading towards the site of the recent detonation.

"Heh, what's shakin', boss?" Bael, absurdly overconfident as ever, towered over Diablo, his frame barely fitting inside the hallway. His favorite weapon, a spiked flail made of demonsteel, was wrapped around his body and the spiky head was draped over his shoulder with the dangerous part resting against his back. He was easily the most intimidating demon that lived among the four Emperors.

"Ah, Bael. It's nothing important." Diablo cast a cursory glance at the two younger demons that stood behind him, the two of them staring at the devils with sad expressions across their faces. "These two were bothering me with a rather mundane request. Their friend was taken by the humans and they want to rescue him."

Bael sneered as Diablo edged past him and headed towards the detonation site. "Cheh, don't you care about the lives of your underlings? They're making a passionate request! You should help them!"

Diablo shrugged as he steeled himself to jump down into the shaft. "Not my problem. Besides, going around humans with their anti-energy weapons is dangerous, even for a devil Emperor."

Diablo vanished a moment later as he leaped down into the shaft, leaving Bael to turn back and stare at the two demons before him. "Dangerous, huh? What'd your idiot friend get himself caught up in?"

Torlok started to speak, but Smealum hushed him, realizing the idiot might say the wrong thing. "We were part of the underground base in London. Davook was our boss, and he had us escape while he held off the humans. We know he was taken alive, because..." Smealum nudged Torlok and he quickly rustled in his pockets to procure the pendant that was glowing red. "...this necklace only glows if he's alive. We suspect the humans are interrogating him... or worse."

Bael nodded slowly. "Hm. Hm. That sounds like it sucks. Well, good on you for trying to rescue him. I respect that! So few demons these days have any honor! I hope your search goes well."

Bael started to turn away but paused as he heard Torlok sigh behind him. "See? Told you nobody was gonna help us. It's just too dangerous."

The massive devil quickly whipped his head back around. "What?! Are you actually implying that I'm scared? Get real!"

Torlok whimpered as he pulled his head back slightly from Bael's outburst. "Ah, sorry m-mister Bael, sir. Didn't mean no disrespect by it!"

"Right. Of course you didn't." Bael quickly wiped at his nose, sniffing silently as he glared down at the two demons. "Let's say I did decide to help you weaklings out. Do you even know where he's at?"

Smealum and Torlok slowly bowed their heads as shame overcame them.

"Right. You don't know where he is, only that humans took him and he's alive. Great job, idiots! You guys will make upper management someday for sure!" Bael slid sarcasm off his long

forked tongue effortlessly as he berated the Animus and Shadow-walker in front of him. "Good thing for you two idiots... I happen to know where they might be keeping him."

Torlok was the first to yank his head up as happiness surged from his body. "Do ya really?! Are ya gonna help us find 'im?!"

"Well... truth be told, I've got better things to do... but if I'm right, you're not joking about the danger. He's probably in The Peeler. I had to go there once to recover a body... it was not pleasant business. I ain't sure who runs the place, but that location is nasty and riddled with humans."

Bael and Torlok stared into each other's eyes for a moment, a sort of kinship forming between them. Smealum blanched as he realized what was happening. *I can't believe it. We found a devil idiotic enough to help us out.*

"You're gonna help us?! Wow! I'm gonna owe you a life debt, mister Bael sir! I'll do anything you ask of me for the rest of your life, no matter what!" Torlok blubbered and nodded enthusiastically as Bael merely chuckled.

"Cheh, I'm the third highest ranking demon in the labyrinth... you'd have to do what I say anyway. Don't get ahead of yourself. I've got to help Diablo finish cleaning up this mess from earlier first. After that, we can move out. I'm hoping we can get there by tomorrow at the latest... I also need to gear up first... charging into human territory is always dangerous." Bael paused, a thin smile spreading across his face. "Well, for a weaker demon, anyway. Anti-energy weapons have less effect on me."

Smealum raised an eyebrow at that statement. "What do you mean by that?"

"You'll see, kid." Bael snickered to himself at a joke the two of them didn't understand.

"No disrespect meant, but my name is 'Smealum', not 'kid'. And this dummy is Torlok." Smealum gestured at his companion as he spoke. "I figured we should get to know each other if we're going to work together."

Bael rolled his eyes as he turned around and started walking towards the bombing site. "Like I give a shit what your names are."

* * *

The smell of blood was making his throat dry up as the hours went on. The Japanese man hadn't come back yet, so Davook was wrestling mightily with his cuffs as he struggled to break free. His left arm wasn't very strong anymore, though he couldn't quite make out the condition of it now. One thing was for sure... it hurt. It hurt like hell.

Davook was putting most of his effort into his right arm, which was clamped tightly to his side. Every time he struggled, a jolt of anti-energy was delivered to his neck, causing him to yelp in pain, but still he persevered. *I won't let this filthy human take my will to fight.*

His left arm screamed in pain every now and then, the flesh most likely comprised entirely of scars at this point. He really just wished he could rip it off and regrow it.

As he grunted and groaned, he was beginning to feel the effects of a mental breakdown coming on. Terror from being unable to escape, coupled with the sounds of dripping water and dulled noises from high above him made him feel like his sanity was slipping. He couldn't move his head an inch, so all of his struggling was done via touch, else he'd never be able to escape at all.

Damn, my arms feel so weak. They're going numb.

Davook stopped struggling and took a few deep breaths. After he had calmed down a little bit and the feeling of fire ants in his left arm seemed to dissipate somewhat, he went back to struggling, wincing every time a jolt of energy surged into his spine.

Alas, his efforts were futile, as his blood ran cold at the sound of a door creaking open in the distance and slamming shut a few moments later.

He's back.

Davook felt his resolve crumbling as the thought of the vile torturer returned fresh in his mind. No matter what, though, he couldn't let that man see him struggling. It would only let him know that he was winning.

"I'm back, fiend." The Japanese man's voice sounded off loudly in the dark room, making Davook wince due to its unexpected volume. Davook hadn't even heard him walking across the damp floor this time.

"Great. I was just starting to get lonely." Davook forced a grin across his face as the man chuckled.

"Is that so? Well, I had some business to attend to. Turns out my dinner date was a vapid, annoying female. I left her with the check and came back as quickly as I could. I guess you could say I missed you too." His tone indicated that he was being facetious, something that Davook didn't miss.

"You're just saying that." Despite his calm and collected way of speaking, Davook felt his nerves cracking as he heard the sound of the human's metal tools clinking on his metal trolley.

"Indeed. Well, I have to say the dissection has gone well so far. I've learned a great deal about the way shadow-walkers manage to blend into the shadows. I had thought it was merely

magic, but it appears your skin can absorb and dissipate light in small amounts, which can be enhanced via the use of magic. It defies the laws of physics as I know them, but that's what I would expect from a monster... after all." Davook blanched as the human suddenly appeared over him, aiming a small laser at his facial skin as he smiled evilly. "You never did tell me your name, monster. I'll be more gentle today if you extend me the courtesy."

Davook gritted his teeth. Truthfully, he didn't want to give up any information to this human, not even just his name... but if he really would even possibly be a tiny bit gentler... "It's... it's Davook. M-my name is Davook." He bit his lip and quickly spit out something else. "There. I gave you my name. Now tell me yours. I would prefer to at least know the name of my tormentor."

The Japanese man paused as he stared down at the demon on the table before him coldly, looking Davook right in the eyes. "You don't deserve such a courtesy... but I've had a dreadfully boring day so I'll humor you. I am Kenichi. You, however, may call me Master Takano. Understand?"

Davook shifted his head very slightly as he poorly attempted to nod. "Yeah. I get it... Master Takano."

"Good. I like the sound of that. It really puts the master-servant relationship in focus, doesn't it?" Kenichi raised his head up and walked away from the table again, his shoes clacking on the damp concrete floor as he pulled some implement off his cart.

"I'm not your servant. I'm just a victim. A pawn for you to get your rocks off on being tortured." Davook felt his anger flare up at the casual assumption that just for giving out his name, he might give out more information. *Not going to happen.*

"Both are true, actually. You are my servant, and you are a victim." Kenichi reappeared over Davook again, this time with a needle in hand. "I didn't mention this before, but I have ways of forcing you to talk. This is a truth serum. Not like the ones in the movies, this merely makes you babble uncontrollably... but it will do."

Davook felt his blood chill as Kenichi hovered the needle over his body. "You... you had that all along? Why didn't you... use it?"

"Come now, that wouldn't be very fun, would it? After what your kind did to my family and my people, you can't seriously blame me for dragging this out just a little bit... can you?" Kenichi puffed up his lip in a mock expression of sadness before breaking into a fit of maniacal chuckling. "Hehehe.... you should see the look on your face. It suits you."

Davook grimaced as the needle suddenly plunged downwards, stabbing him directly in his heart. He started to gasp, but his body was spasming uncontrollably and no matter how he

wriggled, he couldn't move an inch. A few seconds later, the plunger having injected its chemicals into Davook's body, Kenichi yanked it out of his chest and snickered to himself. "Hurts, doesn't it? I added a few extra chemicals to really make it burn. You won't die, fortunately, but soon you'll wish you had."

Davook tried to speak but could only make choking noises as he suddenly found it hard to breathe.

The human smiled pleasantly at him. "Well, as soon as you're ready, feel free to start talking. I'll record everything."

Davook gagged and choked as tears streamed down his eyes. *I want to die. I want to die. Please, devils in hell... let me be released from this torture...*

* * *

Amelia sat on the hospital bed, waving her legs back and forth as her patient was escorted out of the room. "Have a great day, Jeremy!"

The old man smiled sincerely back at her as he hobbled forwards on his cane. "You too, sunshine! You've made my stay a pleasant one!"

He left the room a few moments later as Amelia tilted her head back and flopped on the bed, staring up at the sanitized white ceiling above. The room smelled like bleach and ammonia, since the cleaning lady had just scrubbed the bathroom half an hour ago. It was kind of disgusting, but at the same time a smell she had grown used to.

The sun beamed into the hospital room and felt pleasantly warm, the feeling of summer encroaching made her want to go outdoors rather than stay inside all the time.

As if he had heard her thoughts, Leviathan appeared in her mind. *Princess, how are you feeling right now?*

"Pretty good, I suppose." Amelia fanned her hand out up in the air in front of her face as she stared at her nails for no particular reason. "I just keep thinking... you know... what if disease and death didn't have to happen?"

I don't follow. Leviathan kept his tone neutral as he listened to whatever was on her mind.

"It's just... people like Jeremy get sick and have problems, and it isn't their fault. Wars happen, but it's not their fault either. Why do people have to suffer due to the actions of others?"

Mmm. Leviathan purred to himself as he thought about her question. *Such is life. Humans are frail, weak creatures.... yet they always desire conflict. The demons and angels are hardly*

any better. They all squabble and fight over differences they once held from generations long past, having long since forgotten the original reason they fought in the first place.

"The original reason?" Amelia quickly rose from the bed, jerking herself up in one smooth motion as she stood up and walked over to the window, staring out at the pleasant flower garden a couple stories below her. "What might that be?"

Even I do not know. I was not there for the original conflicts, nor did I care about them. Such small trifles simply did not interest me. I suspect, however, they fought for dominance over the world. Whoever had the most land could spread out their kind over it the most effectively. In the end, it was all just for their own goals.

"It sounds so... selfish." Amelia opened up the window and hopped out of it, falling two stories and landing smoothly without making a sound as she adjusted her nurse outfit to make sure it wasn't tugging in the wrong places. "Why fight over dumb stuff like that? I mean, they have Heaven and the labyrinth, right? They can make all the space they want. There's no reason to fight."

Amelia took off walking as she smiled sweetly at a group of men, all of whom cocked their heads to glance at her with very naughty looks while they walked past. *Heaven and the labyrinth did not always exist, princess. Once upon a time, the angels and demons had to share the Earth together. This was a time before the humans arrived.*

"Were you there for that?"

Somewhat. As I said before though, I do not recall much of it.

Amelia nodded as she walked along and entered into a pet store, stopping to pet a kitty that walked up to her and meowed. She liked to come here sometimes to clear her mind.

"Actually, Levvy, there's something else..."

What is it?

Amelia picked up the cat and cradled him in her arms, scratching him under the chin in the way he liked it. A few customers milled about looking at rabbits and birds on the other side of the small store. "That demon... when I last talked to Jason, those soldiers said they captured a demon and took him to the... the... The Peeler... it sounds awful..."

Amelia swallowed as she felt Leviathan's eyes narrow in her mind. *You're worried about the demon? You've really changed, princess.*

"I mean, you know... he's a demon, but still. I keep thinking that maybe we should check on him. Jason doesn't seem to care about the demons at all... not these days, anyway."

Leviathan seemed to shift in her mind as he thought about it. *Locating one demon in a city of humans should be rather trivial. I'm not sure why you care, but I could find him for you... if you really want me to.*

Amelia set the cat back down as she walked over to a big golden lab that was meandering around the store. As she walked up to him, the dog's lolling tongue retreated into his mouth as he tentatively growled at her.

Amelia took a step back from him apologetically. "Nice doggy... you never do seem to like me. Maybe you sense what I really am, huh, boy?"

She sighed before turning back to walk out of the shop and continue walking down the street again. "Yes, I do want to know where he's located. I just want to see... The Peeler... it sounds so awful..."

Leviathan sighed in her mind. *Haah... well, princess, if you must know... give me a moment.*

Amelia paused and stared up at a church in the distance as Leviathan seemed to concentrate deeply. A moment later, Amelia took a sharp breath as a small amount of energy surged from her body, traveling in all directions as far as she could see.

Seconds turned into minutes as she took a seat on a bench, before she felt the energy return. *It is done. I have located numerous demons all throughout the city, as a matter of fact. They're scattered in clusters here and there, though to what purpose I do not know. There is, however, one demon all by himself, located underground a mile from here.*

"Really? You found him?!" Amelia gasped at the thought. "That was so fast! Levvy, you're amazing!"

Of course. Still... this demon is in bad shape. If I didn't know any better I'd say he was... being tortured.

Amelia's amazement fell flat as her emotions returned to a darker neutral expression. "I see. It's as I thought, then. Tell me where he is. I'm going to go pay a visit to him."

That hardly seems necessary, princess. Jason already said he'd send a clone to investigate.

"I know. But... I want to see for myself. I want to see the true face of humanity. Maybe if I can figure out why the humans and demons fight, I can put an end to this war."

Leviathan paused, as is not wanting to contradict her, yet disagreeing with that statement. *I wouldn't recommend it. You can't bring a war to an end with some pretty words. Still, I won't stop you. He's being held captive under a hospital, to the northwest. You've been there before, actually. It was the one where Jason painted that image for you.*

Amelia turned red at the thought of that portrait. "Oh. Um, right. That one. A-anyway, where is the demon then? Where are they holding him, exactly?"

Underneath, in a cellar or basement of some sort. It's a quiet place, and you'll have no trouble finding it with my help.

Amelia nodded as she stood up quickly. "All right. Let's go, then."

Leviathan hesitated before responding. *Ehh, not to contradict you, but your outfit...?*

Amelia quickly glanced down, realizing she was still wearing her nurse uniform. "Well, we *are* going to a hospital. Can't hurt to blend in a little."

Fair enough.

The dragon kept his qualms to himself as she took off walking towards the hospital she had been at only a day before.

"It's crazy to think that he was so close the whole time."

Part 348a: Pretty Monster

"I feel so nervous." Amelia slowly walked into the hospital, noting that there was only one person in the waiting area and a receptionist. The usual hustle and bustle from a week before had been replaced with emptiness and relative silence. Amelia's ears, better than those of a regular human, could detect the nearly inaudible beeping of dialysis machines and such inside of rooms down the hall, but aside from imperceptible breathing sounds, little else stirred the air.

Even the smells were mostly nonexistent. Compared with the noise and activity outside, the hospital felt like a ghost town. Amelia turned right as she entered the door and headed down a hallway that indicated she was heading towards the ER section.

There's nothing to be nervous about. Leviathan grumbled from deep inside of her as he examined the building around them. There must be an entrance to the underground around here. Keep your eyes peeled.

"Right." Amelia swallowed slightly as her feet clicked every time she took a step forwards. Her half-inch white heeled shoes made quite the commotion compared to the deathly silence that filled the building. "W-was it always this quiet here?" She practically whispered, feeling anxious that her voice was making so much noise. She almost felt guilty, as if her voice would disturb the small scattering of patients in nearby rooms.

By most standards... no. I can sense less than fifty humans in this entire complex. Several of them are merely the staff. You've healed up the great majority of the people here.

Amelia nodded as she walked up to an elevator, pressing the button to call it to the ground floor. "Yeah, that makes sense. I don't know why, it just feels so different here from what I remember."

Those are just nerves. Calm yourself, my princess. You have to keep your wits about you. We might be walking into a trap.

Despite the ominous words, Amelia chortled. "A trap? That's cute. I suppose such a thing might exist, but I doubt we've gotten so soft it could do anything to us."

Hmm. Perhaps. Leviathan mused to himself as the door to the elevator opened.

Amelia stepped inside and noted with dismay that they were already on the lowest floor it could go to. "Darn. We'll have to try something else."

Leviathan seemed to nod in her mind as she walked off the elevator and looked around. "Can't you tell where the passageways and stuff are? Find me an access door of some sort."

I can't, my dear. I can sense living energy and its position relative to us, but not inanimate matter. Jason would be better for this sort of thing.

Amelia scowled as she looked around. "Well, forget him. We'll find our own way."

As she stared back and forth, she spotted a man walking towards them from down the hall. He was an older man, probably in his 40's or so, though that could be deceptive with the nano-machines and such these days. His white lab coat held a name card that indicated he was a surgeon on this floor.

"Err, um, excuse me!" Amelia meandered towards him, her heels clicking on the floor as she walked. "Sir!"

The man looked up from a datapad he was typing on in his hands. "Hm? What is it, young lady?" His expression was that of a vaguely bored man, yet there seemed to be some agitation visible on his face. "I'm quite busy right now."

"Oh, sorry to bother you." Amelia quickly shifted her expression to an apologetic one. Glancing forwards she quickly scanned his name tag. "Could you, ah, help me, Mister Takano, sir? I'm trying to find an access door to the lower levels."

The man's eyes shifted slightly as he seemed to stare at her with more interest. "The lower levels? I can't see why you'd want to go down there. It's quite filthy, not the place for a pretty little thing like you."

His eyes seemed to rove all over her body, a feeling that made Amelia vaguely uncomfortable. "I'm, ah, not worried about germs or anything! I just need to find an access door, if you can... err... help me?"

She forced a flirty smile across her face, even though his eyes seemed almost lascivious. Smiling at him and encouraging any sort of advance almost made her feel nauseous, but still she kept it up valiantly.

"I see. Well, if you want to go there so badly, I won't stop you." Oddly, despite his slight hostility towards the idea of her going down there before, he seemed perfectly fine with the idea now. "It's down the hall and to the left. There's a janitorial closet with a red switch. Press the switch and the door will unlock."

Amelia started to respond but he leaned forwards slowly and interrupted her. "Are you, perhaps, here to make a deposit?"

She felt unnerved by his words but decided to play along. "Y-yes, actually. I am."

"I understand. The caretaker will be there to greet you when you arrive." Doctor Takano smiled at her politely and bowed his head, as his Japanese heritage seemed to indicate he would do. "Have a pleasant day, miss...?"

"Greyheart. Amelia Greyheart." She forced another smile through as he quickly started walking past.

"Excellent. A pleasure to meet you. That uniform really suits you well." Doctor Takano continued walking down the hall towards the hospital entrance and soon he was out of sight.

The moment he vanished from view, Amelia felt her knees start to shake as she leaned against the wall. "Th-that man... he was... scary..."

For once, Leviathan was the one to express confusion. *Are you alright, princess? He seemed relatively normal to me. You appear to be very shaken up.*

Amelia felt her face pale as a cold sweat swept over her. "No... no his eyes... those weren't normal eyes... Levvy, remember all the... the people we killed? They used to scream in terror and... they said my eyes were hollow... the eyes of a demon."

Mmm. Yes. As I recall, you always laughed at that comment.

"I'm not kidding, Levvy. That man wasn't human. Something about him was off, very askew. Maybe this was a mistake."

Leviathan sighed in her mind. *As I said before, you don't have to do this. Ask Jason for help. Going alone into possible danger is never a good idea... even if I can protect you.*

The mention of Jason's name made Amelia flinch, as she quickly found her resolve returning. "No... I won't ask him for help. He thinks of me as weak and helpless. He'd never say it, but I can see it in how he talks to me. He means well, but I can fight in my own way. I'm going to find that demon... and I'm going to save him."

Leviathan raised an eyebrow slowly. *...Really? I didn't think you would declare your intention so strongly, nor did I know that you felt this way towards your future husband. Truly, the nuances of human speech and body movement evade me. So many subtleties.*

Amelia nodded as she stood up and began quickly walking down the hall towards where the creepy man had told her to go. "Let's do this quickly now... I don't know who the 'caretaker' is, nor do I want to find out."

Of that, we can agree.

* * *

This is it... I can feel myself slipping.

Davook breathed hoarsely, his arm now in so much pain that his brain had merely switched off the feeling. Master Takano had already started work on the other arm, but Davook felt so far gone that there was no chance of making it back.

Information... I don't even have information... I gave him everything... I broke completely...

Davook felt the tears flowing down his face freely. His pride was long gone now, after this last round of torture. Master Takano was going to cut off both of his feet next. *He even told me he was going to cut off my hands, make me into a freakshow... he's... he's a true demon...*

His chest was hardly rising and falling anymore. The chemicals he'd been forced to inhale, along with the unending pain in his heart meant that breathing was a job he had to actively work to succeed at. But... it wasn't worth it...

Davook could feel it all slipping away. At the least, he'd die before the demon returned. He would pass on before the monster came to take more from him.

It's not like it matters. There's nothing left to take but my soul.

Davook opened his eyes slightly as he stared up at that same goddamned patch of wetness on the ceiling above him. *My... soul? Will I be reincarnated when I die? Do demons go to heaven? Hell? Are we... already dead?*

He choked back a hoarse cough as he felt blood drip from his nose and stream down both sides of his cheeks. The questions didn't matter, not so long as the end came quickly. All he wanted now was for the pain to stop.

As he had these thoughts, his blood chilled suddenly. The sound of... the door. *The door.* Davook's eyes shot open as panic flooded his mind.

He's back! No! It's too soon! He just left! I don't want him to come back! Leave me alone! LET ME DIE!

Davook wriggled in terror as his voice was unable to escape his body. He couldn't even scream in fear. His throat had been burned by those chemicals that monster had forced him to ingest. Only a silent terror could fill his heart now.

...The sound of clicking heels made Davook's movements stop. *What? Those don't... sound like his shoes? What's going on?*

A quiet breathing could be heard approaching as the heels clicked closer. Davook tried mightily to turn his eyes to the side, but the blinders made it impossible to see anything not directly in front of him.

Suddenly, the most beautiful, heavenly voice spoke out. "Oh... my gosh... are you...?"

Davook felt his heart stop as the face of an angel appeared before him. A beautiful female, human in appearance, her long black hair and cute white nurse's outfit making her seem like a divine piece of manna from the heavens.

"Huhk... hoak..." Davook choked as he struggled to speak, but the beautiful woman quickly pressed a finger to his lips.

"No... don't speak. I'll get you out of this.... thing." Her face disappeared and the light she seemed to give off vanished from his sight.

No... please... don't go... don't leave me... Davook felt more tears roll down his face.

A moment later, an odd sound could be heard. The sound of... metal peeling from metal?

Davook jerked in surprise as the incredibly strong contraption surrounding his head was yanked free, a horrible high-pitched screeching filled the air as the metal was torn off cleanly in one movement.

Davook jerked his head back, suddenly realizing he was free to move, as he gawked in disbelief at the young woman, holding a several hundred pound massive chunk of machinery in her hands. A moment later, she lightly tossed it behind her, the machinery smashed into the wall and crumpled up, leaving no doubt that she was filled with an immense strength.

A few moments later, she had torn the restraints off his arms and legs and was gently helping him sit up, the motion making him feel queasy.

But, strangely... he didn't feel weak anymore. He pondered it for a few seconds before he remembered the needle that had been connected directly to his spine. *It must have been pumping me full of anti-energy constantly to keep me weak.*

Davook glanced down at his left arm. It was in... horrid shape. Massive chunks of flesh were missing here and there, his arm looking like a wildfire had been let loose on it. Even his right arm didn't look so good, something the woman seemed to quickly notice.

She quickly stood up and walked in front of him, bringing her face close to his. "A shadow-walker, hm? I've heard about you guys before. You don't seem all that scary up close- yes! I know, but I don't think he's any danger."

She seemed to be talking to someone else, but there was nobody else in the room. Davook didn't care though, as her soft complexion this close to his face made him feel weak in the knees. *Without a doubt, she is the most beautiful human female I have ever seen.*

She quickly hovered her hand above his left arm. "I hope this doesn't sting too much. It can be unpleasant at first."

Hm? Unpleasant? What does she mean? Davook asked himself the question before finding out a moment later, as agonizing pain shot through his arm, before being replaced by a soft, warm sensation. Glancing down, his jaw dropped as his arm began to knit itself together and heal in a matter of moments.

Ah, I understand now. She is no normal human. She must be a demon in disguise, one similar to Mistress Belial, who is acquainted with the healing arts. Truly... I... I am blessed...

Davook felt a smile spread across his face, as within a minute his arm was fully healed. Before she could get to work on the other one, he pointed at his throat with his nearly healed arm. The girl glanced at him in confusion before a look of recognition spread across her face.

"Your throat? Is it hurt?"

He nodded excitedly, like a little child receiving a Christmas present, as she smiled at him and quickly began to heal it too.

A few minutes later, Davook sat staring at her in awe, as his body was now fully healed. He no longer felt weak, as she had also apparently given him some energy too.

"You... saved my life... what is your name?" Davook choked back emotions as he gripped the table tightly. "I owe you... a life debt."

"I'm Amelia. I came because I heard of your capture. I didn't... realize this was as bad as it was. We have to get out of here."

Amelia started to turn away but Davook grabbed her hand, as he felt his lip tremble. "I am known as Davook. I... I will do anything for you, no matter what you ask of me. I am yours, forever."

The girl paused as she smiled awkwardly. "That... really isn't necessary. But um, thank you! Seriously though, we need to go." Her smile turned into a look of unease as her eyes darted around the terrible workshop covered in old blood stains.

Davook nodded dumbly as he smiled at her with a lopsided grin. "Right, yes. Anything you say, my lady."

She pulled away from his grip and the two of them quickly began to walk towards the exit, when she suddenly halted in front of him.

"Uh... Doctor Takano? Why are you... here?"

Davook blanched as he felt fear engulf his heart. *Not... not the monster...*

Davook peeked around Amelia's body to see the Japanese man standing at the end of the hallway, several Enforcers visible behind him as all of them trained their weapons on the two of

them.

"As I thought. A demon spy sent to rescue one of your own. It looks like I'll have another one to add to my collection."

One of the troopers behind Takano lowered his weapon slightly as he pulled his mask down to stare at Amelia more intently. "...Son of a bitch. I recognize her. Saw her just a couple days ago... with the Supreme Commander!"

Amelia took a step back as she also seemed to recognize the man. "You... your name is... Bubba? And the other men behind you... they must be...?"

Bubba glanced at Takano's backside. "This is bad, Kenichi. She's the Supreme Commander's personal wench. If she's a demon, that means..."

"He's in cahoots with the demons. Always knew there was something a little too perfect about Commander Hiro's rise to power." Doctor Takano sighed as he shook his head. "Now I have to start all over again with that shadow-walker. He's already broken too. Won't be as much fun, this time."

Amelia and Davook took a step back as she quickly yelled out. "You're making a mistake! I'm not a demon, I'm a human!"

Takano chuckled as his eyes flicked over to a massive lump of metal crushed against the wall, the one she had tossed aside earlier. "As if. I saw it in your eyes earlier, you know? The eyes of a demon. I looked into your recent activities, and it would seem that healing up eighty percent of the human hospital population didn't set off any alarm bells in Central Command. I wonder why."

"It's cuz' she's fuckin' the Supreme Commander!" Bubba exclaimed this delightedly, causing Takano to groan.

"Obviously, idiot. Incapacitate them. I want these subjects alive."

"S-sorry. Understood."

Davook trembled as the squad of goons aimed their anti-energy weapons at the two of them.

"Stay behind me." Amelia spoke quietly as she gritted her teeth together. "I didn't want it to come to this, but now that it has..."

Davook nodded as he took a step back around the corner. *Allowing a woman to take the heat. How... weak of me. Pathetic.*

Part 349a:

"You're making a mistake!" The demoness yelled at Takano and his group as she jumped to the side, narrowly avoiding a barrage of anti-energy gunfire. The tight quarters of the underground tunnel left little room for evasion, yet Takano found himself irritated by how springy she was.

"Shoot her, dammit!" Takano fired his own blaster at her as she jumped away once more. The filthy shadow-walker was being a coward and hiding around the corner. Already, he was probably too broken to fight back. *The mere sight of me must be filling him with dread.* Takano licked his lips in spite of himself, as the thought of that wretched demon huddled on the ground cowering in fear filled him with glee.

The demoness jumped from floor to ceiling and wall to wall as she zipped around and dodged. Even the crack-shots in the Bravo Team that had taken the shadow-walker with ease were having the damndest time locking onto her position.

She's more agile than expected, and also seems to be avoiding hostility. Why is she doing this? Takano knelt down to steady his aim as he fired another shot towards her, which she easily dodged.

The demoness lurched to a sudden stop, taking a split second to steady her footing as she jammed her hand into the concrete floor and yanked upwards, sending a wave of dust and concrete chunks flying at the group of men as they yelped in fear. A moment later, they quickly realized it had merely obscured their vision and dealt no actual damage.

"Fuck it, I'm ending this!" Bubba stood up suddenly as he reached behind himself and pulled out a grenade attached to his coat. "Get down!"

Takano nodded as he quickly turned his head away, listening as the sound of the pin was pulled and the grenade was hurled down the corridor. A moment later the demoness gasped as a shockwave blasted outwards, knocking the group of enforcers off their feet. Takano quickly turned back to look down the corridor, and smiled evilly as he saw the female laying on the ground, clutching her stomach as she rolled around in the fetal position.

"Nice throw. Shoot her quickly!" Takano had barely let the words loose before a hail of anti-energy shots blasted down the corridor, peppering her body with enough force to render her unconscious immediately. She didn't even have a moment to scream, as she slowly raised her arm towards the corner where the shadow-walker was hiding before she lost consciousness.

"Got 'er. Now let's get the other one." Bubba quickly stepped forwards uneasily as he pivoted his gun towards the section the shadow-walker was hiding at.

At the moment, something unexpected happened.

The lights went out.

Every man in the room felt their blood chill as a voice spoke in the darkness.

" Well well, looks like someone left a light switch over here. You're going to pay for hurting that goddess. "

Two golden eyes appeared just down the corridor as the shadow walker stared them down. "**Now I'm pissed. "**

Bubba yelped as he turned his gun towards the eyes, but they closed and a moment later a squishing sound could be heard as something with the consistency of a watermelon hit the ground. Following this, Bubba's body slumped over and fell to the side, his head missing.

Every enforcer was breathing heavily as they quickly switched their helmet lights on and swung their heads around wildly, trying to figure out where the monster was at.

Takano took a step back as he forced a nervous smile over his face. "P-putting on quite the bravado, aren't you? Come on, soldiers! Shoot anything that moves!"

The enforcers all quickly started to fire forwards in different directions as they attempted to pinpoint his position, but Takano narrowed his eyes as he noticed something odd. *Their shots are becoming slower, more sporadic.*

He'd hardly had that thought enter his mind when the firing stopped completely. Turning around he looked back in shock as he saw all of them were laying down, as if sleeping on the job. Their helmets lay on the floor, slowly wobbling around as if they had just fallen off moments before.

"Tomahawk...? Squid? Eagle?" Takano felt his voice rasping as the horrible truth set in. He was all alone now.

" Sorry I killed your friends. I'll make sure you die slowly to make up for it. " An ominously high pitched voice spoke just inches from Takano's head in the darkness, causing his steeled frame to shatter as he screamed and fired wildly at the voice's source.

The gun stopped firing as Takano blinked in surprise.

Both of his hands were gone.

* * *

Davook released the body of his tormentor as a smile passed over his lips. *He's dead now. I feel so... happy.*

He shook his head slowly and blinked thrice as he came back to his senses. The ecstasy from killing that human had felt unlike anything he'd experienced before in his entire life.

Glancing around he walked back over to the light switch, flipping it back on as he snickered silently to himself at the carnage he had caused. Bodies lay in piles here and there, ten dead in total, and all of them had been felled by his own hand.

Quickly he hopped over to where Amelia was laying, as the joy vanished and was replaced with concern. "Miss Amelia...? Are... are you all right?" He reached down to touch her hand but jerked back in surprise as she quickly opened up her eyes and rolled into a sitting position in one smooth motion.

"Nice job! I knew you had it in you!"

She smiled at him pleasantly and he responded by staring at her dumbly. "Didn't... weren't you shot? Are you injured?"

Amelia pulled herself up to a standing position as she patted her nurse's outfit down, wiping the dirt off that had yet to bury itself into her nice white clothing. "Injured? Not a chance! Their shots stung but that grenade was a little bit disorienting. I'd say that was the worst of it."

He nodded slowly at her apparent perfect condition. "They must have hit you a couple dozen times. How can you be in such good condition? No demon should be able to take that kind of pummeling and live to tell the tale, let alone walk away in mint condition."

Amelia frowned at him before casting her gaze around at the bodies in the room. "Didn't you hear me? I said I was a human. I wasn't lying."

As she walked over to the headless corpse of the 'Bubba' fellow, Davook carefully digested what she had said. "You're human? That can't be possible, unless you're also a Hero or something. And... were they telling the truth? Are you... with the human's Supreme Commander?"

Amelia sighed as she turned to face Davook down, a look of annoyance on her face. "I am. We're actually going to get married, as it happens. Does that change anything?"

"But... I am a demon. We are enemies." Davook rapped his fingers together in front of himself as he shifted his feet around, obvious discomfort visible in the way he stood. "Humans and demons cannot coexist."

"Perhaps. You might be right. I disagree though... I think peace is possible. I also think..." Amelia curled up her lip in disgust as she glanced back over at the corpse of the doctor that had

been so brutally torn to pieces. "...he was an evil man... but it wasn't my place to decide his fate. You deserved to make that decision."

Davook crossed his arms as he stood up a little straighter. "You're lucky that you're as hardy as you are. That man... he would have... without a doubt... he would have treated you as he did Nerissa. I could tell by his aura. You must be more careful."

Amelia shrugged as she started to walk towards the exit. "I could tell he was a bad man in a single glance... but he could see into me as well. We shared a kinship of sorts."

Davook followed along behind her, noting with interest that she didn't seem affected by the sight of all the dead bodies in the slightest. *This female has done much killing in her life. She is no innocent angel... yet her strong female presence excites me.*

The two of them stepped over the bodies and made their way up the shaft before arriving back in the janitor's closet that had started it all.

Davook hesitated before they stepped out. "I still hate humans. Even you cannot change that... you are merely the exception, not the rule."

Amelia turned back to stare at him intently. "I know that, Davook. You don't have to be the good guy here... they hurt you badly. You can hate them all you want."

Davook bowed his head as he stared at the ground. "I don't mean it like that. You are the only human who has ever shown me kindness... yet you are not truly a human. You are more demon than human." Davook paused as he jerked his head up. "Ah, that is to say, I mean it as a compliment."

Amelia rolled her eyes as he tried to smooth over the pseudo-insult with his high-pitched whiny voice. "I get it. Thanks, I guess."

Davook scratched his lip as he decided to speak his mind no matter what. "You must return with me to the labyrinth! You will be welcomed there as our friend! We will treat you as a revered ally."

Amelia didn't hesitate as she immediately shook her head. "No can do. I knew you were going to say that... so predictable. Look, I have many friends already, Davook. I saved you because what was happening to you was wrong. Don't take this poorly, but I'm no more your ally than I am your enemy. I have prior obligations."

Her sharp retort made Davook blanch. "Of... of course! I should have realized... I meant no disrespect. We shall go our separate ways, then."

Amelia nodded at him slowly as they walked out of the closet. "Do you know your way back to the labyrinth? Need a way out of town?"

Davook turned to look out the window, noting that the sun was already lowering and the day was drawing to an end. "That won't be necessary. I know the way."

"I understand." Amelia turned to walk away from him but paused a moment as she fidgeted slightly. "Well, you went through a lot, so I guess this much is okay."

Before he could react, she quickly turned back and gave him a light peck on the cheek. "Don't think too much about it."

A moment later she walked away briskly, leaving Davook to his thoughts. He rubbed the spot on his cheek as he felt his body temperature flush. *She... kissed me?*

He'd never been that interested in a female before, but this was a different situation. Davook pondered to himself what to do as he started to walk in the opposite direction, towards what his instincts told him was the rear exit.

Honestly, I'm lucky to be alive. I was at death's door. I will never forget this debt.

Davook smiled as he walked past a hospital room and glanced inside. The smile disappeared as he saw an old man breathing through a set of tubes, several wires placed in his arms and chest.

Hunger.

Davook felt an inner voice sprout inside his mind as a wave of nausea suddenly overtook him. Falling to his knees, he felt his vision pulse slightly as his eyes were strangely drawn to the old man's body.

Feed.

The demon wiped at his eyes as he blinked hard. *What is this feeling? It calls to me...*

Devour.

Davook licked his lips as he eyed the snack inside that room. Never before had he felt a pang this intense. It was as if every pore in his body wanted whatever that human had. The feeling from earlier... the thrill of the kill... a filthy human...

Who was going to miss one decrepit old man? Even this man's family didn't care about him... that's why they left him here all alone.

Sustenance.

The voice called to him from deep within as he drooled incoherently and slowly pulled himself into the room. *His family, eh? They might taste pretty good too.*

* * *

Torlok and Bael zipped between alleyways as their Animus friend Smealum followed up in the rear. The night sky overhead was barely illuminated by the fading light of a distant sun. By now, the Moon was the main source of light that they were seeing with.

Despite his size, Bael could move relatively silently, which was a good thing given the humans and their hatred of anything demonic. He flicked his gaze up at the Moon overhead. Its surface was visibly dotted with various colonies of humans, here and there. *Greedy animals. They already had Earth, but they had to take over two other planets too. They truly are insatiable.*

Despite his words, Bael felt jealousy more than anything else. The humans were taking everything from his people... from their lives to their home, the humans truly knew no end to their evil.

Of course, the demons had committed a few inconsequential atrocities... but those were nothing compared to the barbarism shown by humans! Indeed, humans were the reason he could never sit on a beach and admire a sunrise. They took everything for themselves, whether they needed it or not. Their kind was a plague on the universe.

Bael and his two underlings rounded a corner as they arrived at their destination. Just across the street, the northwestern Military Hospital was visible in all of its glory, the lights inside having been shut off once visiting hours were over. Bael smirked to himself. *Humans are evil, it is true... but the thrill of defeating them one day fills me with hope. There is no joy like that of crushing a strong foe!*

"Is that it?" Smealum spoke up, his voice dripping with disappointment. "A hospital?"

"Yeah." Bael's deep voice rumbled in the darkness as he cautiously exited the alleyway and starting walking across the barren street towards their destination. No humans were in sight, and he couldn't smell them either. They were all indoors, snug as bugs, wholly unaware that a demon powerful enough to level their entire city was roaming about at this time of night. "Lots of military types are in there, though. Keep your guard up. I'll take point."

Torlok fidgeted as they walked forwards. "Think we'll see any action? Maybe get ta' cut a couple o' fleshbags up?"

"Don't forget the mission. We're here to rescue your idiot friend. If anyone comes to fight, I'll be doing the punching. Got it?" Bael beckoned to the flail wrapped around his body as the smaller demons nodded softly.

A few moments later, they arrived at the front door. Bael immediately sniffed the air, crinkling up his face as the hospital doors opened up automatically. There was a familiar stench in the air... the smell of death.

Torlok and Smealum gasped in unison as they entered, shocked by the sight of the wall behind the front desk that was covered in blood. Several body parts that once belonged to humans littered the hallway. A corpse sat several dozen feet away, his face frozen in a state of panic.

"W-what the hell? What happened here?" The animus, Smealum, whipped his head around nervously. "All these bodies... but no police or anything. Does nobody know about this yet?"

Bael leaned down, keeping his eyes peeled for movement, as he swiped his stubby fingers across a blood-stain. "Fresh. Something killed these folks recently. Real recent. Must've been in the last hour or so."

Torlok perked up his ears as he took a step forwards. "Y'hear that? A humming sound."

Bael squinted as he forced himself to listen more carefully. Indeed, there was a strange vibration in the air, as if the molecules themselves were being agitated by an unknown force. It was not an alien feeling, though. In fact, it was one he had experienced many times before, personally and impersonally.

"Evolution." Bael nodded slowly, as the other two demons glanced up at him in surprise. "A demon is evolving... right now."

Smealum was the first to speak. "That can't be possible. Satan has said that demons can only evolve inside of the labyrinth. Even if a demon wanted to, he wouldn't be able to." His careful expression indicated total disbelief at even the possibility of such a thing.

Bael chuckled at the naivete of the young Animus. "You believe everything you are told? Satan has many secrets... ones even the top generals and his fellow Emperors are not privy to. This is likely one of them." Bael licked his lips excitedly as they began to move towards the source of the vibrations. *An evolution outside of the labyrinth? Even I didn't think it was possible.*

As they stepped over the bodies of humans, Bael began to feel a tiny sliver of doubt in his mind. *It must be that Davook fellow. But if he didn't evolve by the will of the dark gods, as Satan said demons do... then he must have evolved in some other way. Could the killing of these humans be the key?*

The three of them arrived at an elevator and Torlok cocked an eyebrow. "Straight up... 's gonna take a while to get ta' him."

"We've got time." Bael nodded slowly as he thought about this turn of events carefully. "But it can't hurt to move quickly. Let's go."

Part 350a: Endless Hatred

It's so warm.

Davook stared into the abyss before him with unseeing eyes, as the warmth surrounded his body. It was a familiar feeling... one he had only experienced twice in his life.

Evolution. I am evolving.

This feeling could only be described as the sensation of being inside a mother's womb. The cocoon that surrounded him was made of a material that formed whenever a demon was born. It was nearly impenetrable from the outside and would not open until its host was ready to exit.

Power overwhelming. Hatred. Rage.

Davook felt the emotions pour into his mind, yet they seemed almost distant. He wasn't genuinely angry, and wasn't truly filled with hate... yet it existed. Deep in his mind, another spoke to him, prodded him, coaxed him into fulfilling his most primal urges.

Enemies must be slain.

A simple command. Davook moved his hand forwards slowly, feeling it slosh through the embryonic liquid that surrounded him. It was completely dark inside his larval stage, but he could tell now... it was time to leave.

His hand stopped a few inches from his body, as he felt it pressing against the hardened shell that surrounded him. His senses felt dulled, yet sharp. Despite being enveloped in liquid, he had no need to breathe... for now.

Gently, he pressed against the inside of the shell. The egg-like object stayed put, requiring more force than he was willing to exert.

Physical power is not needed. I have another way now.

Davook closed his eyes as he let his hand fall back down to his side. His mind was all he needed.

A moment later, he released the energy from within, exploding the cocoon outwards in all directions before falling forwards and stumbling onto the floor. It was not a graceful exit, but it was a resounding success.

He coughed and sputtered as his normal breathing mechanisms resumed. "Kahhh... how long...?"

His vision slowly returned as he recognized the place he was in. The administration section... the top floor... the 13th floor. Corpses surrounded him, long since cooled and stiffened as rigor mortis overtook them. Expressions of terror enveloped the faces of the humans all around him.

A smile crept over his face. "Scared, were you? So was I. You knew I was down there, yet you ignored my plight. This is your reward."

Davook grabbed hold of a desk and pulled himself up, staring with a confused expression and wondering why the desk seemed... bigger. Had it always been this tall?

No. Wait, that's not it at all. I am smaller.

Davook blinked as he noted that the colors of the world around him were gone now. All he could see was black and white. Glancing down at his hands, he stared intently as he realized his arms had become so black as to almost be transparent.

It is as if I have... become one with the shadows.

Davook turned back and grabbed hold of the door handle, feeling annoyed that it was now almost at his eye level, being only a few inches below his chin.

How odd that an evolution would shorten my height.

Davook pulled the door open and casually stepped over a corpse from his rampage earlier as he stared out a window. It was pitch black outside, in the dead of night. Davook caught sight of a clock on the wall, noting that it was just after 1 AM.

Two hours. That seems to be far less time than it took for me to evolve into a shadow-walker.

He looked down at his hands again and frowned.

I need to find a mirror.

Taking a quick look around, he spotted a human bathroom. Quickly walking inside, he immediately spotted the massive mirrors on the walls and was shocked by what he saw.

His body no longer had what one might call 'skin'. Instead, he seemed to almost be made up of a black smoke-like substance, one that flowed off his body in wisps and curled up into the air above him.

A word appeared in his mind, one that came unbidden.

Shadow.

I am a Shadow. No longer one who walks among the shadows, I have joined with them.

It was a curious thing, the process of evolution. A strange voice often would appear in the mind of a demon following their evolution to tell them their new designation.

But... this was very abnormal. Shadow? No such creature existed. Davook had heard of shadow-walkers that evolved before, though it was a rare thing to happen... but they always became Wraiths. In fact, he'd only heard of half a dozen who had done so, and all of them had died during the Great War in Heaven, hundreds of years before.

Davook paused his thinking as he felt something odd. He was not alone.

He glanced down at the floor as he felt his presence cover every inch of the building, every nook and cranny where darkness could be felt.

Of course there were the three demons approaching his location, he had sensed them minutes before from within his cocoon. No... this was something else. A human.

Davook sniffed quietly as he turned towards the bathroom stalls. Someone was huddled in the stalls, still alive, breathing as silently as they could.

What a joke. They must think they can remain undetected. Impossible.

Davook calmly walked over to one of the stall doors, pausing as he heard shallow breathing on the other side. This human must have heard his footsteps approaching, for they appeared to be trembling in fright.

"There's no need to fear. Death comes for all, eventually."

Davook spoke and was mildly amused that his previous shrill voice was gone now, replaced with a deep voice, bubbling over with brimstone and fire.

He pressed on the stall and heard a squeak on the other side, as the human revealed herself to be a female. She had locked the stall, though that was no obstacle to him now. Pressing lightly against the door, he melted through it, phasing into the other side effortlessly, as if the door didn't even exist.

The instant the woman saw him, she screamed.

A terrible, annoying sound. The sound a weakling might make just before their end arrived.

Davook didn't even bother to dirty his hands, as the shadows in the stall came alive, darting forwards like knives and stabbing her a thousand times over in the blink of an eye. Her screaming was cut short in an instant as she slumped over against the wall and fell off the toilet seat, all life gone from her body.

Davook smiled again, as the feeling of death washed over him. What a beautiful, melancholic feeling. Leaning down, he pressed her long brown hair against her face and inhaled deeply. *Now you are where all of your kind belong... in the afterlife.*

Davook stayed there for a few moments before walking out of the bathroom, glancing down the hallway towards the demons that approached him now.

One of them is an Emperor. How strange that an Emperor would come to see me. What might I have done to deserve this honor?

The three demons rounded a corner and stopped as they were finally able to see the one who had such an ominous presence.

"D-Davook? Is... is that you?" A shadow-walker spoke up and Davook immediately had to resist rolling his eyes.

I see now, my compatriots must have sought help to try and rescue me from the humans. Too little, too late, though their efforts are not unappreciated.

Davook hesitated before responding. Was it just his imagination, or was he able to perceive a strange line of shadow emanating from their heads and stretching up into the ceiling before disappearing? As if they were marionettes on a string. Surely, it must have been his eyes playing tricks on him.

"Torlok. Smealum. And... Fourth Emperor, Bael. A pleasure to see all of you."

Bael shoved the two smaller demons out of his way as he strode forwards, a broad grin on his face. "Well, would you look at that! An evolution outside of the labyrinth! Don't we have a real mystery on our hands here, eh... Davook?"

Something about the way he said Davook's name stirred up a feeling of disgust within the Shadow's inner self. As if he were looking down on the small demon.

"Is that jealousy I detect, Emperor? Do you crave something I possess?"

Bael's smile cracked as his eyebrows lowered. He glared down at Davook, a strange look in his eyes. "I'm just interested... in what you've become. Never seen a demon like you before. Are you the first of many... or perhaps... a unique evolution?"

Davook smiled back at Bael, his white molars having now been replaced with pure black husks of darkness. "Unique? I am unique, yes, as are all demons. I am not part of some hive-mind. You, on the other hand..."

Davook stared past Bael, up at that strange black thread of darkness that seemed to go from his head up towards the nether above. It was almost like Bael were some sort of puppet being controlled by a marionette master.

"...speaking of hive-mind... how is Satan doing these days?" Davook phrased the question casually, almost too casually for one with an ominous presence such as he. Bael immediately seemed suspicious.

"I ask the questions here, pup. How did you evolve without being in the labyrinth? Why have you evolved into something previously unseen?"

Davook ignored the questions. "I see. You didn't come here to help me or to save me from the humans... you came for your own selfish reasons. Perhaps not even your own."

Smealum had been silent this whole time, but now he spoke up. "Bael came to help. You should be thankful that an Emperor would give you his time of day. Especially when the labyrinth, our home, is being destroyed by the humans."

Mentioning humans made Davook blink a few times as he seemed to come back to his senses. For a moment, his bloodlust had been about to boil over. "Right. I do not trust Bael, no matter what you say his intentions are. In fact, I trust none of you. You're all... pawns. Weapons to be used by your superiors. This is truly unjust."

Bael snarled as he glared down at the short little demon before him. "You're acting pretty cocky, little fellow. What say I make you eat those words, eh? I'm no puppet, but I can break your body into pieces and turn you into one. Besides... I've been wondering what the extent of your strength is. Your body is smaller than that of any evolved demon I know, yet your power is unmistakable. Won't you humor me with a fight?"

Davook returned the glare as he took a step forward and stared up into the eyes of the Fourth Emperor. "Asking permission? That doesn't sound very regal. Perhaps you admit that I am no longer below you? Hell has only one rule; the rule of strength. Those with power lead, and those without... bend the knee."

Bael's temper was flaring up as he knelt down, keeping his face within a few inches of the former shadow-walker's. "Are you calling me weak, filth?"

Davook calmly smiled back at the angered face inches before him. "I'm merely stating what I see. You could try to persuade me otherwise, if you like."

Bael didn't hesitate as he lunged his hand forwards, grabbing at Davook's neck. The moment he started to move, Davook was gone.

" Relying on primitive body movements, are you? You'll need to do better than that. "

The shadows themselves seemed to shudder as a voice whispered through the corridors. The darkness itself seemed to come to life as the newly arisen Shadow began to display his power.

"Hiding, as a coward would. Your fear is palpable." Bael rose to his feet and looked around slowly. The Shadow was still here, somewhere. But where?

Where was the insect hiding?

Part 351a: Allegiance

Bael clenched his fist as he unwound the flail from his body. A bead of sweat dripped down from his forehead, causing him to wonder for a moment if the room's temperature had increased, or if it was just his imagination.

A flicker of movement made Bael jerk to face it. It appeared to be nothing, but he was wary, as the flail twitched in his hand. "Where are you, maggot? Come and face me."

"Demons should not fight other demons. Humans are the enemy." A voice spoke from all directions, seeming to come from the walls themselves. "The humans count on us and our infighting to divide us. This is how they are winning."

"I don't give a shit about that!" Bael flicked his flail, causing it to surge forwards and smash out a window and the wall attached to it, the noise being deafening at this time of night. "I just want to test you. I just want to fight!"

"Is that all?" The voice paused and Bael caught a glimpse of a shape forming down the hallway, as Davook reformed himself from the shadows, smoke turning into a physical form as he stood nonchalantly with one hand on his hip. "Go ahead, then. I'm right here."

Bael barely hesitated to consider if this was a feint, lunging his flail forwards at the figure encased in smoke. The moment he did, he felt a strange sensation under one of his feet. A moment later he slipped and toppled forwards, the flail falling flat just as he did.

"I control the shadows. I am the shadows. You are fighting in my territory, now. Give up... I do not wish to fight one of my own kind."

From down the hall where they had taken cover, Smealum and Torlok watched in awe as their mentor and leader battled one of the four demon emperors, and seemed to even be winning. "This is crazy. How did he get this strong just from killing a few humans?" Smealum whispered so as to not draw the ire of Bael, though now he was beginning to doubt that their boss would let the big guy hurt them.

"Always said, man, th' boss is one tough cookie." Torlok grinned eagerly as Bael rose to his feet again. "He's smart too. Not just some big dumbass who throws a big ball o' steel 'round. He likes ta' get in yer' mind when he fights."

Bael stared ahead silently for a few moments at the shadowy figure at the end of the hall, taking a moment to think. "The shadows are your ally, then? I see." His strange calmness was something rarely seen. "Then it follows... the light is your weakness."

"Correct." The shadow leaned against the wall without a care in the world. "By fighting me at night, you are fighting in the worst possible conditions. You should leave now, lest you face another humiliating defeat. Wouldn't want a repeat of that encounter with the current Supreme Commander, would you?"

Bael's calmness vanished in an instant as he gritted his teeth and felt a vein pop in his forehead. "You... bastard... how do you know about that?! No shadow-walkers were present for that battle!"

"Correct, again. I was an imp at the time. I managed the portals that allowed the demons to enter and exit. I heard tale of how the hero smote you with the Holy Sword, Excalibur. You shouldn't feel too ashamed. After all... even you are too *weak* to hold up against the condensed power of the Holy Sword."

The shadow seemed to snicker to himself as he spoke the word *weak*. Bael didn't find it amusing.

"I am not weak! I am strong. Blows that would kill a weaker demon merely stun me. Even Diablo fears my wrath! Satan instated me as his fourth Emperor because he understands my true power!"

The shadow pulled away from the wall and walked forwards slowly. "Big words, for a weakling. Satan uses you as a pawn. I see the shadow attached to your mind... to the minds of all demons. Satan knows you are stupid and would never question his authority. Even Diablo is not intelligent enough to see... the truth about demon-kind. We're all toys for Satan to use as he sees fit."

Bael smashed his foot into the ground to root himself properly, once again lunging forwards with his flail at the shadow. "What are you blabbering about?! Just die already, you impotent little shit!"

Bael smiled to himself as he felt the shadows shifting around his feet once again. *A one-trick pony... he still isn't used to his evolution abilities yet. He thinks of me as an idiot to test his powers on. Let's... change that.*

The Fourth Emperor stabbed his free hand forwards, delicately flicking a light-switch on as all the lights in the corridor flooded the hallway. Davook took a step back and screamed in pain as the flail hit him, blasting him into a thousand pieces... his body evaporated into mist and a strange feeling of pain could almost be felt in the air.

"Heh... and here you thought you were invincible." Bael pulled the flail back quickly as he clapped his hands together. "Care for a round two? Maybe I killed you. If I did, you're even more pathetic than I thought."

Torlok bit his nails as he glanced down the hallway. "Th-that looked kinda brutal... hope th' boss 's okay..."

His concern was addressed almost immediately, as the lights in the hallway went out again, this time with a fizzling noise.

A voice spoke from the darkness, once more. "That was... unexpected. You made me admit my weakness, then used it against me. Smart. However, this much light will merely inconvenience me. Only a pure light, brighter than the stars in the sky... only a light like that could truly harm me."

Bael quickly flicked the switch again, only to feel dismayed that the lights wouldn't turn on. "Did the flail even hurt you?"

"No." The shadow reformed again, this time much closer to the Fourth Emperor. "It merely dispersed me. My body should be impenetrable to physical attacks now. As for the lights, I've severed all the connections in the building, since the inside of the walls are covered in darkness. You will not be able to use that trick twice."

Bael nodded solemnly, his anger and rage gone now. "My biggest weakness as a demon is my inability to use magic. This is also my strength, as the human weapons that harm other demons have little effect on me. If my physical attacks won't harm you, then you will inevitably win this battle."

"Mmm." Davook grunted, neither affirming nor denying the sentiment. "Whether I win or lose matters little. However, I am no longer part of the labyrinth, as of today."

Torlok stepped out of hiding, walking forwards a few steps as he stared at his boss in confusion. "No longer part o' the labyrinth? But... but... what about us?"

"You are close allies of mine, and former subordinates. As of today, we are no longer working together. I have my own ambitions to fulfill." Davook reach behind himself and touched the spot on his neck that still seemed to sting ever so slightly. "The human who captured me... he inadvertently gave me this power. I suspect that he severed my connection to Satan by pumping me full of anti-energy."

Bael narrowed his eyes as he examined the lack of expression on the shadow's face. "Severed your connection? Explain."

Davook's voice had an edge of sadness to it as he spoke again. "It's simple, really. You're all being used. Satan somehow is able to steal the soul energy of those you kill, then give it back to those who he deems worthy... without his influence, demons would evolve much more rapidly

after killing one another or humans... or angels. Everything we've been told about our evolutions... is based on lies. Satan is controlling the demons for his own gain."

Bael crossed his arms and smirked. "I've known Satan for millennia, whelp. He's not that kind of leader. Even when all the demons were wiped out, he still fought for our kind. He sought to rebuild our numbers to their former glory, and he never gave up in the fight against our oppressors."

"Precisely. Think about it, Bael. You're not as thick as I first presumed. When the War in Heaven was fought and the angels and demons were wiped out en-masse... did Satan seem to grow in power around that time?"

Bael shrugged at the question. "Everyone who survived became stronger. What's your point? You think you can change my allegiance with pretty words? Satan is the strongest of our kind. I won't question his authority after all these thousands of years. You weren't even there when we invaded Heaven, so don't act like you know what happened."

Davook sighed as he turned around and started to walk away. "You're right. I wasn't. But I see it clearly now, the strings he uses to hold you in place. Only one who has the ability to see these strings will understand. I will take my leave now."

Before he could disappear, Bael reached forwards and grabbed him by the shoulder. "Wait. If you're leaving the labyrinth... doesn't that make you an enemy? A rogue agent?"

Davook pulled away from Bael's grasp and glared at him slightly. "I have no interest in Satan's schemes. Despite his manipulation of our kind, he is performing decently. I have my own goals to attend to. You will not see me again unless I have found a way to rid our kind of the humans for good."

Smealum decided to speak up, seeing his former boss was about to leave. "Davook, come on... you don't have to do this. You should stay with us and help us fight back against the humans! You have power now!"

"Power, yes. This power is not one I asked for, but it feels right. However, that name... Davook. I feel as if it no longer suits me. The name was given to a buffoon of an imp." Davook paused for a few moments before shrugging. "I shall think of a new one, given time. For my old comrades, I will not forget you. I will always be watching from the shadows. Take care, friends."

The three demons barely had time to register his parting words before he evaporated into mist.

Davook was gone.

* * *

I swing my paddle deftly, knocking the small ball back at the holographic recreation of a tennis champion from the 21st century, marveling at how he always seems to be able to anticipate my reactions. These holograms are becoming more advanced all the time!

He barely even moves as he swats the ping-pong ball back at me and I return it in kind, before he finally whacks it too fast for me to catch it.

"Jeez. Another perfect round. I really suck at this." The digital scoreboard hovers in the background, as if to mock me, making my digital opponent's score pulse blue. 10-0, my loss.

"You did your best!" The man cheers me on with his mechanical sounding voice, but all it does is make me feel worse.

"Hologram off." I barely put any life into the words as the simulation shuts down. I quickly grab a towel nearby before it disappears and wipe my face down, then I head out the door.

The holo-deck opens directly onto the kitchen and dining area, so when I walk out, I'm mostly unsurprised to see Amelia sitting by herself on a sofa with her legs tucked under herself, reading a book.

"Oh! You're back." I walk over and take a seat next to her, conjuring myself up a small glass of light beer... something I've been trying out lately. The beer tastes like shit but it makes relaxing a lot easier.

"Yep." Amelia barely even acknowledges my presence as I sit beside her on the couch. She's not wearing her nurse uniform, so she must have been back for a while now. I do like the cute blue sundress though, it fits her well.

"What'cha reading?" I flick my eyes over the book but they glaze over immediately. It doesn't look like a fiction novel or anything I'd find interesting.

"Advanced psychology... learning about how to help patients who have experienced a lot of... trauma." Amelia seems colder than usual, but when I put my arm over her shoulders, she leans back into me and rests her head on my chest just fine. She doesn't seem to want to put the damn book down though... almost as bad as when cell phones were a thing and I could never get people to look me in the eye.

"Trauma, huh? Had a lot of patients like that lately?"

"Just a few." Amelia shrugs lightly as she thumbs the page over and reads the next one. "Trauma has a lot of long lasting effects. It's too bad we don't have better ways to deal with it."

"Medical technology is advancing steadily... brain augments will get there eventually, I think." I take a sip of my beer as I glance away from the book over at some fish swimming in their fishbowl.

"Yeah... but brain augments are kind of... I dunno..." Amelia's words sound casual enough, but I can't help but notice that she seems very bothered by something.

"Are you doing all right? We haven't talked much this week."

Amelia finally sighs as she sets the book down. The movement makes me feel slightly guilty, like I stopped her from enjoying her reading time. "Well... a lot of things have happened lately."

I nodded along neutrally. "Right..."

"I mean, you know how it is right now. The demons are being destroyed, our hospitals are being emptied out..." Her voice trails off as if she wants to say something else, yet fears my reaction.

I poke her in the ribs jokingly. "Mhm. Go on..."

She seems to fidget at my touch, but finally continues. "Well, I had this patient today... he suffered a lot of pain and wasn't acting the way he normally might. Someone hurt him... really bad."

"That's terrible! What happened?" I keep my questions neutral, noticing that she's playing with her long black hair now, going out of her way to avoid eye contact with me. She's such a child sometimes.

"I... don't know exactly." Amelia says this and I immediately can tell she's lying. She knows exactly what happened. Still, it's not polite to call her out forcefully, so I'll wait. "All I know is that he was badly scarred up, and even when I healed him, he still carried the pain in his heart. I'm worried about him."

"Well, that's good of you. I've been hurt badly before too, physically and emotionally. The only thing that will make the trauma go away is time, I think. I've had nearly two hundred years, but most other humans haven't lived nearly that long."

"Yeah... humans. Listen, Jason, actually it's more that... he... uh..." Amelia starts to say something else but I hear a familiar sound as a teleportation occurs right in the middle of the kitchen and a familiar figure is left standing there, getting his bearings.

"Sensei?" I pull my arm away from Amelia and quickly stand up, noticing that he doesn't look to be in a good mood.

"Jason. Good thing I found you so quickly. Listen, something really bad happened on Earth not even an hour ago. An entire hospital staff and all of their patients were brutally murdered. You need to get down there immediately."

My teeth grit almost involuntarily as he delivers the news. "You're kidding. Who would do such a thing?! It must be the work of the demons... or a serial killer. But we've weeded out most

of those personality types though, so..."

Sensei nods vigorously. "I've barely had a look at the scene, but other clones are looking into it. The thing is, this happened at the place I told you about."

I stared at him carefully for a moment. "The Peeler? You found it?"

"Yeah. Turns out it was hidden under the same hospital that was butchered."

"Christ." I quickly turn back to Amelia and offer an apologetic look. "Sorry, but our talk has to be cut off early. I need to check this out."

Only then do I notice a look of horror spread across her face. "I... I'm going with you. I need to see this... for myself..." She quickly gets up and walks over to me. "Bring me with you."

I almost want to deny her, but the way she asks the question makes a weird feeling appear in the back of my mind. Besides, if it's just bodies and corpses, I'm sure she won't be affected by it anyway... she's not some innocent child after all, and neither am I.

"Alright. We'll go. Let's continue that conversation when we get back though, okay?"

"Uh... sure." Her response sounds anything but confident, but I don't have the luxury of time to question her.

I turn back to Sensei. "I don't know which hospital it is, so you take us there."

"Can do." Sensei aims his mind at Amelia and I. " **Return.** "

Part 352a:

Realistically... I've killed a lot of people in my life. Many demons too. I've seen a lot of death, and it never seems to end. Without fail, as a famous philosopher once said, 'all beings must eventually die'.

But even I'm not ready for the scene at this military hospital. It turns out the killer struck the same hospital that I painted at, the one where Amelia healed many people. To think that not even a week ago, this hospital was a lively place for those who fought valiantly on the battlefield to recuperate from their wounds before returning to their normal lives... men and women who lost friends and family to the demons, and they were all butchered while they were at their most vulnerable.

The moment I walk in the door, I'm immediately greeted by a small contingent of my clones who are surveying the scene, and their expressions are anything but pleasant.

"Sensei, glad to see you back. This must be Original." One of my clones nods at me, his face pale due to the horrors he's seen. "We all quickly wordsmithed ourselves into a contingent of world-class crime scene investigators, and we've dug up a lot of leads."

"Do you know who did it?" Out of the corner of my eye I notice a body nobody's had the time to wrap up in a bodybag yet. The woman looks like she's been impaled by a ridiculous number of knives, and her face is frozen in mid-scream.

"Sort of. It was a demon, that much we know, but the wounds across all the bodies are... inconsistent."

"Inconsistent? How so?" I ask this and my clone fidgets uncomfortably. He must be one that hasn't seen as much death as the others who fought on the frontlines against the Volgrim.

"It's... hard to explain. Many of the bodies have their necks slit cleanly, but the further we went up the building, the more varied the wounds became. Some people had their heads ripped clean off, others had holes punched in their chests. One man had his entire spine and ribcage ripped out. That was... awful. One of the worst."

"And her?" I tilt my head towards the woman lying on the ground. "Those holes look very unnatural."

"You said it. She's still a mystery. It's like she was impaled by a hundred wooden stakes, the kind you'd use to kill a vampire or something. But there aren't any wood splinters in her body, and all of the wounds happened at the exact same time. She died instantly."

As my clone speaks, I can't help but notice that Amelia looks beyond worried. She seems downright guilty, as if she's desperately trying to hide something.

"Amelia. Any ideas?"

I shoot the question at her and she flinches visibly. Her reaction tells me that there's definitely something going on here. I quickly look back at my clone. "Keep at it. Let me know if you find anything else."

"Sure thing." My clone nods uncomfortably and walks away, leaving Sensei and I alone with Amelia. Sensei's a pretty smart clone, and given he was the first one I ever made in this timeline, I feel a closer kinship with him than I do the others. He also seems to notice that she's hiding something.

"Amelia, is something wrong? You look bothered about something." I kneel down a little bit so I'm not towering two feet over her, and this seems to help her regain a little bit of composure. Why would she be intimidated by me? Even if she's hiding something, it's not like I can slap the shit out of her or something. Without my Hypersuit, she's actually way stronger than me, though I do wonder if she knows that.

"Well, err, it's about the, uhm... the talk we were having." Amelia looks into my eyes and forces the most hollow false smile I've ever seen in my life. And of course, she starts to play with her long hair. She always does that when she has that guilty look on her face.

"Right. The talk. Just spit it out, I know something happened."

She seems to grimace at my words, but I'm not one for dancing around with feelings, and it's not like I'm going to punish her if she did something wrong.

"Weeeeell, you see... that demon that was in the Peeler... I kind of... sort of... found him. And released him."

"Oh."

My mouth speaks one simple word, but my mind instantly explodes with the implications.

"So you... you let him go?"

"Yeah..."

"And he was under this building, in the Peeler..."

"...Yeah..."

"And we have a whole bunch of dead people now."

"Pretty much..."

"And they were killed by a demon."

Her face scrunches up as I say this, but she seems to have a moment of positivity in the face of this catastrophe. "It could be... any demon? Maybe? Not necessarily the one I saved?"

My throat feels drier than usual as I swallow hard. "Somehow I doubt that."

Sensei shuffles awkwardly as he takes a couple steps back and eases away from us. "I'll just... leave you two. You clearly have things to... discuss."

As he walks away, I feel anger boil in my mind, but I stuff it down. "Why did you release this demon? You know demons hate humans! That's like kicking a hornet's nest and wondering why you were stung!"

Amelia crosses her arms and glances to my side, unable to maintain eye contact. "You didn't see it with your own eyes, Jason. The person holding the demon was a torturer... he was barbaric! He hurt that demon badly!"

"Exactly! So if you let the demon go, obviously he'll have a grudge and take it out on whoever is closest! Think next time, Amelia!"

Amelia's voice lowers as she takes a step back from me. "You think this is bad, Jason? Butchering innocents is never good, but what about you? You're dropping nuclear bombs inside the labyrinth, killing demons by the millions, if not billions! Have you ever stopped to think about how this will affect their actions towards us?"

"That's not how it works. The demons have wanted humanity dead long before I arrived on the scene. The difference is that now humans have invented nuclear weapons, and the demons demonstrated they're perfectly willing to use them against us. It's us or them. We can't coexist."

Amelia seems irritated by my words, but she takes a moment to calm down before replying. "Okay, what about the future? You said humans were inside of... bubble worlds or whatever. Isn't that a form of coexisting?"

"Well, sort of. None of the humans had any form of advanced technology. Apparently the demons would come and attack their worlds periodically or something to keep them in line and prevent them from advancing technologically. That's beside the point anyway."

I take a deep breath and exhale slowly as I consider what to do next. "Why didn't you tell me? I could have helped you out."

Amelia curls her hair onto her finger and then back off as she seems to debate a response. "I don't know, honestly. You always treat me like I'm helpless or like you're afraid I'll do something wrong. You act... like you're still afraid of the me from the future you came from. That's not me, Jason."

Despite the horrible scene we're standing in and the solemnness of the moment, I feel a smile spread over my face. "Well, I mean, to be fair... you did let a demon loose and he killed a bunch of people. You have to admit that was pretty dumb."

Amelia is trying to resist smiling but she fails as we both finally return eye contact again. "Yeah, I guess you're right. I messed up. Sorry." Amelia immediately frowns obstinately as she quickly waves a finger at me. "But that doesn't mean I did the wrong thing, Jason! I won't let anyone, human, angel, or demon suffer! Torture is not the right way."

My smile fades away as I look at the ground. Truth be told, she's right. Torture isn't good. Now that I think about it, that demon may have committed this specific atrocity out of vengeance for what that torturer did to him. And really, would I prefer that he be tortured to death? Would I want that... for Belial?

Belial... Gregory... while rare, I have known a few demons that were not evil. They allied with me for various reasons, but I never got the idea that they were trying to stab me in the back. As for Satan, can I really call him evil? He's far older than me and has seen things I haven't. From his perspective, humans are evil.

It doesn't change anything, though. I have to kill off all the demons. I just... need to do it quickly.

"You're right. Torture isn't the way. Well, anyway... that demon you saved... do you know anything that can help us out?"

Amelia shrugs. "He was a shadow-walker, and a rather big one at that. His voice was really nasally, but beyond that we didn't talk much. His name was Davook, if that helps."

"I have no idea. Never heard of him." I turn to walk towards the crime scene and Amelia follows along behind me. "Did you guys talk about anything important? Anything useful?"

"Um... well, he did say he hated all humans... I didn't think much of it at the time."

I barely even flinch as she tells me this. "Of course you didn't."

* * *

This city was very hostile to non-humans, but luckily Belial was not like other demons. She looked very human, with creamy white skin and no demonic horns like the others of her kind. The only thing that stuck out about her was her cute little tail, of which she was very proud... but still, she had to cover up with far more clothing than she would usually like to be wearing. The tail would just have to stay tucked.

A drone buzzed overhead, scanning the area for non-human lifeforms, and likely demonic and angelic energy patterns. Naturally she possessed a ridiculous amount of such energy so it

blared right above her, making her cringe. Even at this time of night, when few people had yet woken up, these damned drones were always out and about.

It took only a few seconds before someone arrived on scene. An enforcer, green level. He was wearing a lot of armor and a mask, but Belial could tell by the way he carried himself that he was a man. After all, he was bigger and more ripped than a female would be... and besides, female enforcers basically didn't exist.

"You! Stop right there!" The man leveled an anti-energy pistol at her, something that would weaken even her to the point of being defenseless. Still, she kept her cool. This was the third time tonight she'd had to deal with this.

Raising her hands above her head, she let her lip tremble as if she was afraid. "W-what did I do, sir? I'm just walking home!"

The man paused as he saw she was a woman. "...What are you doing out at this time of night?" He took a few steps closer but kept his gun trained on her. "That drone flagged you as a demon."

"I-I'm not a demon! I don't even have any horns! Come on, I'm just walking home!" Belial suppressed a laugh as she forced herself to keep a straight face. A little more emotional manipulation and this man would be hers to toy with.

As he walked closer, he seemed to increase his breathing tempo. "W-well, it might be an error... but the readings were off the charts..." Soon he was just a few short steps away, the radius at which her succubus aura would begin to take root quickly.

"Y-you're not going to hurt me... are you officer? I thought men of the law wouldn't take advantage of poor helpless women."

She forced a high pitched tone into her voice, though even for herself this felt rather silly. Still, he fell for it, hook line and sinker. Quickly, he tucked his gun away as an odd smile spread across his face. "No... uh, you're right. Terribly sorry. My name is uh... Jim. W-what's yours?"

"Jim? What a masculine name. You seem like a pretty tough guy." Belial lowered her hands as she slid over to him in one smooth motion, touching his face. The instant she touched him, he had lost. No human male could resist the power of a succubus caressing his skin.

"Wha... what can I do for you to-today?" He mumbled and stumbled over his own words as his smile grew to intense proportions. "Your wish is my command." He reached into his pocket without even looking and pressed a button, causing the drone to fly away without complaint.

"Oh, how I love it when an idiot says that." Belial's tone flattened now that she had already won. "Tell me where I can find the Supreme Commander's residence."

The man's smile faded as a look of guilt spread across his face. What a failure he was, being unable to answer such a simple question. This failure would haunt him for the rest of his life.

"I'm... sorry. I don't know where he lives. I'm just a low level Enforcer. Nobody tells me anything. P-please forgive me!" He quickly grabbed her shirt with a forcefulness that surprised her, as he seemed to be unable to control his lust. "I want you! Let me taste your skin!"

"Get the fuck off of me." Belial's expression darkened as she reared her hand back. A moment later, she slapped him with the force of a freight train, sending him flying backwards and smashing into a wall. Were it not for his armor, the impact would have shattered his spine.

Belial didn't care, however. *Nothing worse than a man who thinks he's owed something of mine.* She straightened her coat's collar as she stared at his crumpled body in disgust. "You'll probably never walk again, but I have no pity for weaklings."

As she walked away, she sighed dramatically. *Three enforcers and nobody knows where he lives. I'll have to aim for someone higher up the chain of command. It's too risky, though... entering their main base. Perhaps if I wait around outside, I'll encounter someone with upper level clearance who knows. The man can't be that secretive.*

As she pondered this thought, she heard the sound of several sirens approaching and quickly ducked into an alleyway. *Damn, did that enforcer alert the others? He didn't even reach for a communicator.*

Her questions were answered as two dozen vehicles went flying past, including multiple ambulances, all of them not seeing his body crumpled up against the wall. They were all headed in the same direction, causing her to wonder what was going on.

Quickly looking back and forth, she nodded as she saw that there were no other drones in the sky. The one from a few minutes before had already flown off. Rushing forwards, she leaped onto the roof of a small house and dashed after the vehicles, keeping herself on the far side of the houses so pedestrians at the street level wouldn't see her.

Several minutes later, she came to a stop and stared in wonder as the throng of vehicles joined another group and ended up at a hospital. One of its upper level windows had been smashed outwards, fairly recently if these members of the enforcement community were anything to go by.

Belial stared carefully though and was shocked to see the Supreme Commander himself, standing alongside one of his clones and a younger looking woman, probably in her twenties. Well, relatively speaking anyways. It was so hard to tell anymore with all the cosmetic surgeries one could get.

"Valac. Are you awake?" Belial reached into her coat and pulled out the ominous black orb and clasped it in both hands as she hunkered down behind a chimney.

"Duuuh. I don't need sleep, beautiful." Valac's voice appeared in her mind, charming as always. Despite his words, he yawned which made her raise an eyebrow, but she didn't care enough to voice her concerns.

"Any chance you can hazard a guess as to which of those is the real Supreme Commander?"

"Aye, maybe. Sorta. I'm not sure how I'm supposed to tell though." Valac rolled his eyes as his head turned in her mind's eye towards the people in the distance. "Well, of those two, one of them has a way higher energy level than the other. He's probably the real- HOLY MOTHER OF SATAN!"

Valac yelled out loudly and made Belial flinch as she took a step back. "What? What is it?!"

"That girl! My god, what is that *thing* inside of her? I-it's horrible! Terrifying! A goddamned monster!" Valac seemed almost panicked as he stared at the woman with a horrified expression on his face. "It's not a demon, or a human or... anything I've ever seen! It's just a mass of evil and hatred!"

Belial squinted down to get a better look at the young woman and shrugged. "She looks normal enough to me. Are you sure you're seeing correctly?"

"Hell yeah I am! There's no mistaking it, she has a vicious monster inside of her! And- oh... oh no... we need to leave. Now." Valac's voice went dead quiet, almost to a whisper, as his mental image trembled. "It... it sees me... it sees me, mistress. We need to leave right now."

Belial nodded as she cursed under her breath. The meeting with Jason would have to wait. Whatever Valac saw, it was serious business. He'd never acted like this before.

As she quickly climbed over the building and fled in the opposite direction, Belial glared at the orb in her hands. "I hope you're not messing around, Valac. This isn't funny."

His ashen face appeared in her mind, a blank expression having overtaken it now. "No... no I don't think I can joke about that. It's not from this world. It was... the personification of death itself. Nothing can stand up to... that thing. Not even Satan."

Belial bit her lip as she jumped to another building.

What the hell did he see?

* * *

Amelia stared up at the house across the street, watching silently as the demon left. Jason was busy talking to the city's mayor, as was Sensei, so neither one of them had noticed... but

Levvy had.

"You're sure she saw you?" Amelia whispered, but Leviathan heard her loud as day.

I did. More specifically, there was something in her hands. It somehow saw me inside of you, and I communicated with it. Nothing verbal, but I assure you whatever it was, it learned the true meaning of fear.

"Let's hope that's the last of them." Amelia finally turned her head back to the conversation Jason was having, now that the demoness was gone. "She felt strong. Even I could sense her power from here. Good thing Jason doesn't know how to sense power innately."

It's likely she couldn't sense you because Jason was nearby. Out in the open, I'm sure she would have said the same thing of you.

"But the thing in her hands detected you, Levvy. Why is that?"

It seemed to be a device of an odd nature. Perhaps it is in a similar position as me, a being of immense power trapped inside that orb. As such, it would be able to sense me while the demon female wouldn't.

"Mmm. Let's keep this between us. Jason doesn't need to know."

Agreed.

Part 353a:

June 2nd, 2117.

Amy groaned inwardly to herself as she heard her car's horn being frantically slammed on, over and over again. *Geez, that girl needs to learn some patience.*

She flicked her eyes around desperately, the awful nagging noise outside nearly driving her up the wall. *Where did I put that damn purse?* She speed-walked into the kitchen, pulling open the oven door just to check. *Not there. Thankfully. I'll know I'm getting old if that happens.*

She sighed and took a deep breath, then found herself wondering about that last thought. *Come to think of it... I'm a hundred and four years old. I've only had one child and that was barely a decade ago. I don't... feel very old though. Certainly not over a hundred... shouldn't I be taking up knitting or something?*

As she stood there tapping on her lip for a few moments, the back door to the kitchen was flung open and her daughter took a step inside before noticing her mother. "Come on, mom! We're going to be late!"

"I know, sweetheart. I'm just... trying to find my purse. I know I left it here somewhere..."

Sarah scrunched up her face in confusion. "What? I already took that out to the car. Let's go!"

Amy groaned audibly before a smile crept over her face. "God, you had me worried for a second. Thought I was getting Alzheimer's or something."

"As if. You don't look a day over thirty! Now stop dawdling or I'll be late for recital!" Sarah didn't wait for an answer as she ducked back out the door, leaving it open behind her.

"Why are you leaving the back door open... the car is out front..." Amy grumbled to herself as she slammed the door and locked it, turning to walk back towards the front door. "Jerry, we're leaving the house now! Go ahead and lock it down in security mode."

The android quickly walked around the corner, nodding his head mechanically. "Response: Yes ma'am! I am ready to defend this house to the last pulse of energy!"

"Aww, you're working on your sense of humor! Ta-ta!" Amy shut the door behind herself as that odd automaton smiled at her weirdly from behind. It wasn't the AI she had expected thanks to movies from her youth, but at least it wasn't trying to go Terminator and kill her. Overall, she considered it a win-win.

Minutes later, she and her daughter were on the road, the radio tuned to a pop station the two of them liked as they bobbed their heads and moved to the beat.

"Last week, I met this girl in choir and we hit it off so well! I think she might be my new best friend or something! She's dating this guy and he's alright but she was asking me if the three of us could go to the beach this Sunday."

Sarah babbled and gushed about her new friends and Amy smiled politely, though she seemed relatively unconcerned about the whole thing. "Yeah, you can go. Just make sure to bring some sun-tan. It's starting to really shine lately. Weird since London has always been a really cloudy place."

"Yeah, I know what you mean. Ever since the nuclear attack a few years ago..." Sarah trailed off for a moment as she glanced out the side of the hover-car to the west. "It's already been seven years but it feels like yesterday. I was just a little girl when the demons attacked us."

"You were, indeed." Amy spoke cautiously as she thought about her own feelings regarding the attack. "The anniversary is next month. I wonder if the new Supreme Commander will take any steps to rename the day, maybe make it a holiday or something."

Sarah scrunched up her face as she glanced at her mom in confusion. "Rename it? Why would he do that?"

"Well, the footage of the attack stirs up a lot of emotions for those of it who lived in fear for years after the attack. Many people think another one is coming, or maybe even that it was a false flag to justify Stonewall's actions against the demons. Renaming it to Peace and Prosperity Day, like some of the news commentators have suggested, would help move those feelings into the past. I think it's time to move on."

Amy took a minor detour, seeing as a traffic accident was making the local Enforcers re-route vehicles to the west or east. Sarah seemed to mull over her mother's thoughts for a few moments.

"Yeah, I guess that might help some people... still, there's something else that's bugging me."

Her tone seemed serious, making Amy glance over at her. "What's that?"

"You! You keep bringing up the Supreme Commander out of thin air! It's like you're always thinking about him or something!" Sarah's expression brightened into a playful smile as she teased her mom. "Dad is your number one though, right? You'd never cheat on him, would you?"

Amy blanched as she stared at her daughter in amazement. "What? Never! I can't believe you'd even think such a thing!"

"I'm just kidding. Jeez." Sarah puffed her lip out as she turned to stare out the window at the buildings they were passing by.

"Ah, sorry. Don't joke about that though. Your father means the world to me... to the both of us." Amy felt a weird air settling in the car and decided to try and make it pass quickly. "Besides, I bet the Supreme Commander is more up your alley anyway."

"What?! No way, he's way too old! I don't ever want to date a guy that much older than me!" Now it was Sarah's turn to look shocked, giving Amy a much needed chuckle as she rounded the last corner and pulled into the mega-church parking lot.

"Well, we're here, Sarah. Have a good day and put your heart into choir." Amy leaned over and kissed her daughter on the cheek, feeling a slight dismay as Sarah leaned away from her. *Right, I keep forgetting she's too old for that now.*

Sarah blushed as a group of people walked past the car and stared inside at them. "Well, erm, anyway! Bye mom, love you!" Sarah climbed out quickly and slammed the door, taking her bag along with her as she headed into church.

I'd love to join you, but work calls. Amy sighed as she watched her daughter walk away. A few moments later, she pulled forwards and started driving the rest of the way to her day job.

* * *

"Uhhhhh..."

I can't believe my eyes. How did she get past security? I'm actually speechless right now.

"Uh? Is that how you really want to greet me?" Belial stares at me and I feel this weird sensation in the back of my mind. She's not just a strong demon, but apparently crafty as hell too.

Here I am coming back to my office in the London HQ to grab some papers, and a freaking succubus is sitting in my personal office's chair, behind my desk. How could she have gotten past the energy scanners? Are they useless? Do they serve any point at all if someone with her power can just sneak in?

Well, at least she's wearing clothes this time. The last time I remember seeing her, she was wearing some skimpy outfit as she likes to do. For once she's wearing an actual feminine business suit. Maybe she infiltrated the place by looking totally normal?

"Belial. I just... didn't expect to see you. What brings you here to say hello?" I quickly close the door behind me as I glance around the room. She hasn't touched anything and appears to have just been sitting here... waiting. She already closed the blinds so no random person

walking past could see in, and my door's sign still said 'Out of the office'... the only question is how long she's been waiting.

She seems miffed for a moment, almost as if my question touched a nerve. "You never called."

"I... beg your pardon?" I furrow my brow as I take a few steps forwards and sit down across from her... on the other side of MY desk. This feels like when I talked to Stonewall in this very room, all over again.

"I gave you my card. When you took me prisoner, you made it sound like you were going to call me. You never did." She crosses her arms and raps her fingers against her biceps impatiently.

"Sorry. I kind of... forgot." I smile weakly and she rolls her eyes in response. "I really did mean to call though, but after everything that happened, I was dragged away and the call slipped my mind."

"Whatever. It's not like the time taken matters, since we're both immortal." She seems to relax in the chair a little bit and her arms slacken up.

"How did you get past security?" I decide to try the direct approach, seeing as this is really bugging me.

"You think I'll tell you? A woman has her secrets." She shoots a cunning smiles at me as I nod in return.

"You must have seduced your way past the men. I'll have to keep that in mind for the future."

She pulls back and her posture stiffens, telling me I was on the right track. "Lucky guess."

"In my experience, Belial, there's no such thing as mere luck. Only knowledge and how you use it. I know you too well."

She seems to appreciate my candor. "Glad to hear it. In fact, that's why I wanted to talk to you. You've been on my mind ever since we last spoke a few years ago."

"It's been a lot longer than a 'few' years." I correct her pointedly and she smiles in return.

"Time moves differently for me than it does for you. If you manage to live for several thousand years, you'll understand. Anyway, getting back on topic." She leans forwards and rests her arms on the desk. "It's about the future. I have many questions that I can't answer, though I'm not sure if you will answer for me. Namely... it's about... Satan."

Despite her pretenses, I can tell now that she's very uncomfortable about something, in a way one conversation won't get out of the way. "What about him?"

"You told me he dies in the future. How?"

"I can't tell you that. I'm not going to answer specifics about the future." I keep my resolve in the face of a woman I once loved, but the look of pain on her face isn't helping make it easy.

"Jason..." Her face shifts and I can't help but notice that she seems to look almost melancholy now. "Even if we were an item in the future... that was then. This is now. I don't want him to die. You've been destroying the labyrinth and killing demons in catastrophic numbers... he'll have to take serious action at some point soon. When he does..." I felt my heart pounding just a little faster as her pupils seemed to dilate slightly, as if a strange feeling was being beamed into my mind. "...are you going to spare him?"

I shake my head quickly, trying to get the oppressive aura out of my head. "I don't know. I won't know until that day comes. Asking me is futile, because I don't have the capability to predict the future. I only know as much about it as I do when it stays on the correct path, and it's already straying now."

"Mmm. I wonder." She pulled back in the chair and seemed unconvinced. "You think it's changing, then?"

"I do."

"Would you say the changes are positive or negative?" She stares at me pointedly and I frown as I try to guess at the meaning of her words.

"I don't follow."

"Well, you're killing off the demons, the Volgrim are gone, humans are soon to become the dominant superpower, and it's likely the angels will fall afterwards. Is this a victory, in your opinion? Have you truly won?" As she hits me with questions, I find myself wondering if she was always this philosophical in the future.

"In some ways, yes. In others, no. My goals have changed though. The future I sought to preserve while only changing the parts that were bad was too indeterminate. I need to change it more dramatically. I need to make sure the demons don't rule the universe."

"I see. And the best way to achieve that goal is to kill all of us?"

"Well, for the most part, yes."

"Even me?"

She stares into my eyes softly and I feel my mind form the word 'no', but my heart relents. "Maybe."

"Hm." She barely seems affected by my opinion. "Why not kill me now? Why bother waiting?"

Damn. She's got me there. "I... I'm still not sure about that yet."

"So that's how it is? I think I'm beginning to get the picture. You'll kill off all of the demons, except for me, and you'll use me as a slave to fulfill your desires. Is that about how you see it? Maybe you'll keep a few other succubus girls too. Can't be locked to one slave when you're the almighty ruler, can you?"

My eyes widen as she says this. "What?! No! That's outrageous! I'd never do that!"

"Are you certain? You seemed to want to make peace with the Volgrim once, and look how that turned out. You eradicated them. You sounded like you weren't really an enemy of my people when we last spoke, yet now you slaughter us. What are you, Jason? Friend? Or foe?" Her expression has darkened considerably, and now she looks really angry.

I struggle to find words and instead opt not to respond. I don't know... if it's just 'demons', then exterminating them seems easy. But... Belial... Samantha... I don't consider her an enemy. I can't just kill her.

"Words fail, then? I understand. This is what I came for, and I've gotten my answer." She seems to sneer at me, almost as if in disgust. "If you wanted a fuck-toy, you could have just asked. Killing off all the friends and family that belong to me, only to selfishly let me live for your own pleasure... you really are nauseating. I don't know what sick future I came from, but if it means that I ever entertained the notion of being with you... I'd sooner impale myself than let that happen."

She stands up from the chair abruptly, interrupting my train of thoughts. "Wait, Belial. Don't go... this isn't the way you think it is. It's not like that." I'm panicking, wondering how the conversation shifted so rapidly. I'm not good with calming down angry people.

"Oh *sure* it isn't. I've known many men, many rulers. I know how men work. You're a selfish, arrogant little shit. You act as if you're doing this for the good of humanity, or whatever noble ambition you might be pursuing, but it's all to preserve the parts of the future that you like. I bet that if you get your wish, it will be humans that rule the galaxy and demons will just be left in groups to be hunted for sport. That's what you really want, isn't it?"

She walks around the desk and starts to walk past me, but I grab her hand that's dangling by her side. "Wait... Lilia. Don't go."

She yanks her hand away from me as a flash of anger blasts across her face. "You even know the name Satan gave me?! I would never share that with you! You must be quite the mind-

controller in the future." She freezes for a second, and I suddenly realize it's not just anger she's feeling. Her shoulders are shaking, as if she's fighting back tears.

"I won't kill the demons then. I'll spare Satan!" I quickly jump to my feet, but before I can say another word, a single tear streaks down her cheek.

"That won't be enough. It's too late for that now!"

My vision goes spotty as a flash of hand movement appears out of nowhere. A moment later, I'm lying on the ground, dazed, as my hearing goes in and out. I close my eyes, then open them a few seconds later as a dull ringing appears.

I'm... on top of something uncomfortable. My back screams in pain as I suddenly realize that there's someone standing over me, waving his hands and yelling something I can't understand. A sharp feeling digs into my back as I painfully notice I'm on top of some rubble. My natural regeneration starts to kick in, aided by Excalibur as I finally comprehend what happened.

She hit me. Hard.

I must have smashed through three series of walls, an attack that would have killed any normal human. If it weren't for my incredibly durable body, I might have been turned into Jello.

My spine screams in pain, as someone quickly touches my shoulder.

"Supreme Commander! I am doctor Nielson, how are you feeling? Can you speak properly?" He shines a light into my eyes as I glance around in confusion.

"Where... did she go?"

The doctor glances behind himself to follow my gaze. "The intruder? She escaped sir. We're in pursuit now. You were unconscious for several minutes. Can you count how many fingers I'm holding up?"

Several minutes? It felt like a few seconds. The pain is screaming in my body, but I can already feel my organs starting to knit themselves together. In minutes I'll be fine.

"Four. I'm alright, doctor. Just give me a few minutes to walk it off, and I'll be in perfect condition." I reached back and rubbed my back, stifling a pained gag as I realized I had landed on a sharp rock that impaled my spinal cord. Luckily, unlike the last time my spine was badly injured, I've already healed most of the damage up.

Belial is gone now, and I doubt the Enforcers will be able to follow her.

That was no mere slap... it was delivered with brutal intent. I almost think... she was trying to end me in one blow.

The woman I once loved tried to kill me. This is definitely a new future I'm headed towards.

Part 354a: Grasp Of Evil

The humans were far too slow, and much too weak. They had no chance of catching her. Belial jumped from rooftop to rooftop with speed and grace, as she fled the scene of the crime.

Not that she considered it a crime. The human known as Jason was a repugnant man. A master manipulator, one who was toying with her for his own reasons.

To think I had any interest in him. He's worse than the worst rulers I ever despised. In the encroaching darkness of the night, her swift form could hardly be seen as she moved with a litheness few had ever witnessed before.

She nimbly leaped down from a rooftop, landing in a small area several blocks away from the London HQ where she picked up a custom built box, given to her as a gift by Satan some years earlier. In retrospect, she mused that it had likely been created by Marie at his request, and Belial was no fan of Marie, but this box was quite useful.

Popping it open, she felt an evil power surge outwards from within as she pulled the orb of darkness out. Valac, as always, seemed annoyed that she had shut him inside a pitch black place like that.

"Great! You're back! I couldn't be happier if I wanted to be." Sarcasm dripped from his voice, his annoyance unmistakable at this point.

"Sorry. You know it was hard enough getting in the building without the orb setting off every alarm for a mile around. Besides, it's not like you missed me, is it?" Belial smiled coyly at the orb and Valac smacked his forehead in her mental vision.

"Get over yourself. You know, you're not the most pleasant person to talk to, but you're the only damn demon who ever touches my orb. Anyway, how did it go with the kid?" Valac quickly moved past his disdain as he inquired about that which had likely bugged him for the last hour or so.

"I might have killed him. Hard to tell." She cocked her head as the sound of distant sirens could be heard. They were still looking for her, and considering she had attacked the Supreme Commander, the consequences would be dire if they found her.

"...You killed him? What?! WHY?! You were crowing about him and touching yourself in weird places and getting all hot and bothered for all those years... only to kill the guy?! Why are females so irrational?!"

Belial rolled her eyes so hard she could almost see the inside of her head. "My god, keep the exaggerations down please, I'll snap my own neck if you keep shouting such nonsense. I held no feelings for him and did no such touching. If you keep grossing me out I'll leave you in a dumpster next time."

Valac sneered as he seemed to lean back into an invisible chair. "As if. What a liar. Only the devil knows how many naughty thoughts you had about that human. I just don't get why you'd attack him... almost wish I'd been there to get the full context."

Belial stuffed his orb in her suit pocket, wondering to herself why she didn't wear such practical clothing more often, before realizing that it was because she always felt so stifled by it. "It doesn't matter anyway, he's probably dead now. Somehow I doubt it, and even if he is, I'm sure that weird clone we saw could replace him. As I recall from when we fought years ago, he has hundreds more after that one. I can't see any way to eliminate him... and he poses an existential threat to our kind."

Belial flinched as a voice yelled in the distance, likely belonging to an Enforcer. Truth be told even a small contingent of them wouldn't be able to stop her, but she was weak to anti-energy weapons just the same as any other demon. More so than some due to her high concentration of magical power.

She started to move but felt ridges under her shoes which gave her pause. *The sewers.*

While not the ideal place to traverse, she shrugged and pulled the manhole cover off, climbing down inside quickly as she pulled it closed behind her. Enforcers would surely check down here, but they would need a special team to be put in place since the sewers were like a maze under the city. Far too easy to get lost in.

The place reeked. It was indeed a sewer, as she crushed a rat that walked too close under her boots without a second thought. The smell was almost acrid and it burned her lungs, plus it felt like she was being watched, even in this near-total darkness.

Belial made a few motions with her free hand as she mumbled a few words and touched her eyes. A moment later, she opened her eyes and blinked quickly as a sort of demonic night-vision allowed her to see things more clearly. She knew from past experience that it made her eyes glow red, which some had called creepy or even scary, while others found it fascinating or endearing.

Truly, anything could be an acquired taste if one put their mind to the task.

Valac grimaced as his gaze flicked all around the place. "Sewer systems... one invention made by humans that I'll never understand. Smelly and useless, it just flushes the waste out of

sight and back into fresh-water down the line. Don't the fools know they're ruining their clean drinking water?"

"I don't... huaaah..." Belial started to speak but found herself gagging as the awful odors entered her mouth. "...don't think that's how it works. It gets cleaned up at the end of the line and made drinkable again. Or... something. I don't know, honestly."

Most demons were incapable of comprehending human technologies. Even the most basic things that an elderly technologically illiterate human could somewhat understand presented a challenge to any demon. Whether it was due to nature or nurture, they simply treated technology like alien artifacts... unexplainable and incomprehensible.

"Humans convert this... this filth... and consume it again? Truly, they treat us like beasts, but they wallow in their own filth and let it flow freely beneath their great cities. Barbaric, if you ask me."

Valac seemed disgusted by the concepts of sewage treatment, but Belial was having other issues. Her eyes were watering due to some unknown chemicals in the air, and her breathing was strained as she walked further down the twisting corridors.

Minutes passed and the two of them kept relatively silent as she wandered in a mostly straight line, taking lefts and rights when dead-ends popped up before her.

She suddenly missed a step and tripped forwards, plunging her leg into the filth and quickly jerking her foot back out in horror. "Augh, seven devils! If the humans used their brains, this would be the model for Hell!"

As she shook her foot, a strange feeling of dread spread over her body.

Valac seemed on edge too. "Belial. We're being watched."

"Mmm." She felt her body tense up as she glanced around carefully. The corridor she was in extended a long ways in front of and behind her, with several branching paths. If they were being tailed, the unwanted guest could be hiding anywhere.

The problem was... the more she looked around, the more she had the feeling that she wasn't being watched from one location, but from everywhere... all at once.

"I... I can't get a bead on them. Whoever they are, it's like they're part of the walls themselves. I can't tell where they're located." Valac seemed increasingly nervous, his disgust from earlier gone.

As for Belial, the fumes in the air seemed to be getting progressively worse. "I... kah... I think they're trying to weaken me. I need to... hngh... I need to get out of here..." She felt her stomach tighten up as pain started to hit her in waves. Quickly she glanced up at the ceiling. She had left

the manhole behind several blocks away and getting back there wouldn't take too long, but this person following them might be waiting in that direction for her.

But why go through a manhole? She had more than enough power to create her own exit.

Steeling herself, she bent down and coiled her legs, rearing her fist back. A moment later, she leaped upwards and punched at the ceiling with one mighty swing of her fist.

That was when things went horribly wrong.

Something unseen jumped up from the floor, grabbing hold of her leg and yanking her down with incredible force, slamming her into the ground so hard that she yelped in pain as a snapping sound could be heard. Belial whipped her head back in horror to see that her leg was broken in an unnatural position, and... something pure black as Death itself had wrapped around, holding her firmly in place.

"What the hell?! Valac! Heal me, quickly!" She barked the order and immediately felt energy rush into her body, mending her leg in under two seconds as she ignored the pain. Yanking with all her might, she pulled and tugged but was unable to break free from its grip.

Seconds later, the unthinkable happened. The walls themselves seemed to come alive as black tendrils shot forwards, grabbing her arms and other leg, wrapping around her neck and body and pulling her limbs in an assortment of directions, making fighting them incredibly hard.

She wriggled and shifted, but no matter how she fought, she couldn't break free of whatever this monster's limbs were. "V-Valac! Give me power! Get me out of th-" before she could finish, another tendril shot from the ceiling, forming a fist of iron as it punched her directly in the face, smashing several teeth from her mouth and spraying blood everywhere.

She blinked as her consciousness wavered between reality and a dream world, as a harsh male voice finally spoke.

" Don't fight it. I'm not here for you. "

She tried to move her mouth but her jaw wasn't working right. Her eyes attempted to move around, but she was feeling a strange sensation wash over her mind, almost as if a presence had invaded her mental barriers.

As she blinked slowly, a figure came into view. A pure black being, comprised of black flames... or smoke... or something otherworldly.

A demon? Belial stared at it, not quite understanding what she was seeing.

" You have something I want. The power of darkness. I have been following you since I learned to see the thin threads of fate that bind the demons of this world to

their master in the Labyrinth. Puppets following a false prophet. You, however, are special. You possess an object that will give me the power to resist. "

Belial mumbled incoherently but she couldn't form words. Valac, however, was able to take up the slack. "What the hell?! You're a demon?! I've never seen an evolution like yours before! Don't you know this is your empress, the Second Emperor of Hell, directly under Satan himself?! Release her at once!"

The strange black demon smiled coldly, as an image of haunting terror spread across his face. **" You think that title gives her power over me? I have no need for those bound to a false master. You, however... you are sentient. Most interesting. I had assumed you were merely an object of condensed power. That is my error. "**

Belial flinched as the black demon leaned over her and gently plucked the orb from her hands, though in her hazy state of mind she could barely even feel it leave her grasp.

Valac scowled as his image appeared in her mind. "Don't let him take me, mistress! I don't like him, he's just too terrible!"

Belial sighed as she felt her eyes beginning to droop. *Really, I just need to rest a little bit. For some reason, I'm more tired than I should be. Take it easy, Valac... hope you don't miss me too much...*

She felt something wrap around her throat tightly and blinked her eyes back open, only to find herself gazing into eyes of pure evil as the shadowy figure stared at her intently, his hand clutching her throat.

" When you wake up and report your failure to your owner... be sure and let him know that trying to find me is useless. I am everywhere, and nowhere, all at once. I am Yama, and I belong to no-one. If he comes, I will put an end to him swiftly and mercilessly. "

He chucked her back to the ground viciously, though Belial didn't even feel her head hit the concrete. For some reason, she was losing all feeling in her body, even the perception of pain.

" Sleep now, wench. Pray that you never see me again. "

Belial closed her eyes, all too happy to obey his command. For some reason, sleep was exactly what she wanted right then.

This would be a nap like no other before it.

Part 355a: False Prophets

Sarah and her entire choir group stared in confusion, halting their singing abruptly right in the middle of a high note.

"An... angel?" One of the boys in the choir blinked twice as he tried to make sense of what he was seeing. Glancing upwards, he and many other people in the audience gawked at the hole in the ceiling. This angel had smashed through the ceiling and slammed onto the stage, rather than appearing with a bright light as Raphael had done on previous occasions. Impacting the stage with his feet and landing without taking any visible damage, his arrival had released a small shockwave that rippled around the room.

Sarah swallowed silently as she clenched and loosened her hands. She moved her eyes to where her mother would usually stand in the audience, but she wasn't here today. She was working, as she always did. Sarah silently wondered to herself what her mother would think of this sudden angelic appearance.

"My friends! I have returned, from beyond the grave!"

The angel's voice boomed around the massive auditorium, defying how a single voice should sound without the aid of microphones and speakers. Moreover, Sarah recognized the iconic voice almost immediately.

"Father Clarence...?" She barely spoke his name, letting it trickle out in a whisper. He stood only a couple dozen feet in front of the choir, his back to them.

If Father Clarence is here, and he's an angel now... then... that must mean...

"It has been a month since the false god slayed me on stage, right before your eyes! The one who calls himself Raphael, an archangel of the highest order... he is a FAKE!"

Clarence's voice sounded much deeper than usual, and seemed to push aside a cloudy feeling in the minds of many in the audience as they gawked at him in confusion. *How can he be standing here?* Their expressions seemed to ask the question non-verbally.

"I was murdered in front of everyone here! Ask yourselves, my friends... what righteous god do we follow? Would the God of the new testament allow one of his angels to smite a prophet in front of his believers? Would the God of the Holy Bible allow such a brutal murder in front of the flock which he leads? No! God is just! God is righteous!"

Clarence spread his wings outwards and beckoned to them proudly. "Look! See how he has blessed me! For my services in spreading his word, I was granted the immortal body of an

angel, and sent forth to warn his loyal sheep of the treachery that has been committed in his name!"

As Clarence gesticulated with his hands, Sarah felt worry enter her mind. *Treachery? What is he talking about? Does he mean the archangel?*

"Remember that day, a month ago, my friends! Remember that I spoke of my failures in life... I am a sinner. I... I am a sinner." Clarence bowed his head for a moment and Sarah felt her lip trembling, as if she was fighting back tears all of a sudden, just the same as he must be doing. She wiped at her eyes and wondered for a moment where the strong emotional shift had come from.

"I... I am a sinner. Yet, God recognized the righteousness in my heart! The false angel who struck me down did not wish for my message to be heard, but you shall hear it now. The angels are using humanity! They are controlled by the demons, and never lift a finger to help us except when it makes them look good! Think, for a moment... think back to when we first saw the angels. They arrived all at once on a field of battle, and killed many Volgrim. But ask yourselves this... have you ever seen an angel kill a demon?"

Sarah raised an eyebrow at his question. *What does he mean by that? Is he saying angels don't kill demons? I mean, come to think of it... I never have seen that happen...*

"The answer is no!" Clarence spread his arms out dramatically as he bellowed at the crowd. "All the angels are corrupt! They're using the followers of Christ to further their own greedy ambitions! Listen, I am not a perfect man... but my heart is in the right place. I opened up my body to the power of Christ, and he has compelled me to act!" Clarence leaned towards the crowd and several of them leaned forwards in return, eager to hear what he had to say next. This was what they had been waiting for. Without Clarence, they had lost their way over the last month.

Clarence isn't lying. He has seen the face of god and been rewarded. It... makes sense.

Sarah felt her posture become melancholic as she listened to him. If what he was saying was correct... then going to Church meant nothing. They were worshiping false gods... giving their praise to liars and con artists.

As if to answer her thoughts, Clarence spoke quietly. "However... it doesn't have to be this way. There is another, one last angel who serves the One True God... she is the one spoken of in your bibles... the mother of Jesus Christ himself! I'm talking, of course, about Saint Marie. She gave birth to the son of god, and as such she is linked to the one true god through a sort of blood union. Behold!" Clarence procured an image from his coat and held it up for the audience to see.

A faded painting of an angelic woman was projected onto the screen behind him, as one of the ceiling cameras zoomed in to give everyone a better view. Sarah glanced behind herself up at the massive viewscreen and gaped at the beautiful woman on the screen. She looked young and fresh, as if she was an expectant mother. The painting was almost sepia-colored and looked very old.

Still, Sarah felt a nagging feeling in the back of her mind. *Did he say 'Marie'? Wasn't Jesus' mother name 'Mary'? It's a small thing, maybe it's just how he says it. Then again, she was originally a Hebrew so maybe this is her real name...*

Sarah didn't quite feel convinced, but still Clarence continued. "Saint Marie is the key! She is the only angel in Heaven that can stand up to the archangels! They have hidden her son away and used their combined power to seal away the Creator, the one true God in Heaven! Please, I beg of all the people in this room, you must stop praying to the false archangels and their false gods, and begin praying to the one angel who can save us! Only true faith will save you from the sins of blasphemy and ignoring the plight of our Creator!"

Clarence fell to his knees, as tears began to stream down his face. His sincerity made several people in the room also begin to cry. "If the traitor archangels have their way, we will perish at the hands of the demons! Don't let them take the souls of your children, and your children's children! You have to fight them! You can't give in! I am here to-"

Before Clarence could finish, a bright flash of light exploded above the roof of the church, blinding everyone and making them shield their eyes as they looked away. A moment later, they looked back up and gasped audibly.

A beautiful woman, an angel who surely was the one Clarence spoke of, floated downwards gently, landing beside Clarence on the stage. She was dressed modestly, yet her face shone like the mid-day sun. Sarah began to almost feel a longing inside of herself, despite the fact the angel was a woman.

"It is... as Clarence has said." The woman's voice was soft, almost demure. "I am Saint Marie. Clarence gained a secret power from the Creator himself and freed me from the shackles that the archangels bound me in. I have come today to implore you... give me your strength... we can fight the imposters, but only if we work together. I am... just a woman after all."

Her soft eyes blinked slowly as she glanced around the audience. Several men who met her gaze took a step back in awe, even as their wives shot them dirty looks.

"YEAH!" The audience roared with delight as they raised their bibles high. Despite being unprompted, their energy was infectious. Even the choir group pumped their fists up, and Sarah felt compelled to follow them.

"I thank you. When we have ousted those who stabbed my son Jesus in the back from Heaven... truly... everyone here will get what is coming to them. You have my thanks."

The audience screamed happily as Sarah found herself grinning from ear to ear. *This is it... this explains why we can't kill those demons! They're being helped by traitor angels! We have to help Father Clarence!*

As the audience whooped and hollered, Clarence and Marie met each other's eyes, both of them nodding imperceptibly to each other.

The ploy had worked... for now.

* * *

Sarah slowly walked out of the Church, a couple hours later, her legs feeling like lead. Her wrist communicator blinked slowly as a new message indicator appeared on its screen, tapping it, she nodded as she read the message. *On my way, sweetie, be there in fifteen minutes! Hope you had a great day at recital! You go, girl!!*

Sarah smiled weakly as she tried to digest what had happened. Father Clarence had appeared back from the dead, he had revealed the angels were traitors to humanity... and now she had a mission to pray to Saint Marie tonight.

She closed off the communicator with a tap as she stared ahead absentmindedly at the front gate. An air-bus flew down from the sky and hovered up front, landing slowly on the ground as people entered it to leave and be flown to their homes around town. *Good to see they're using public transport and helping the environment.* Sarah scratched her chin as the bus left.

Looking around absentmindedly, she walked over and sat on a bench, noting with disinterest that an old man was sitting on it as well. As she sat down, he spoke up almost immediately, making her cringe. *Oh great, a chatty Cathy.*

"Hey, how ya doin' young missy?"

She carefully glanced over at him, noting his disheveled hair and the stains on his brown coat. He looked like a vagabond. *Damn. I shouldn't have sat here so casually. Now it'll be awkward if I get up and walk away.*

"I'm fine, I guess." She kept her tone neutral as she glanced away, trying to put off a vibe of polite disinterest.

The old idiot didn't seem to get the picture. "You're a real cutie! Say, do you go to this here church too?" He had a real pep in his voice and when she looked back at him, she couldn't help but stare at his nasty browned teeth.

"Yeah. I'm in the choir."

"Oh wow, so you must've been right behind them angels when they appeared, eh? Father Clarence, back from the dead! Ain't that a sight ta' see?"

"Mhm. It was really something." Sarah turned away again but she could feel him staring at her expectantly, waiting for her to continue the conversation, and it was making her feel weird. "Uh, I'm not sure though... the whole thing just felt... off."

"Mmm. Mmm. You noticed it too, then, eh?" The old man's smile faded somewhat as his voice dropped in tone. "Them angels sure seemed fishy to me. Seemed like Father Clarence wasn't quite bein' honest with us, if I do say so myself."

Despite her misgivings towards the old man, Sarah found her curiosity piqued. "Not being honest? What do you mean?"

"Oh, you know... old fart like me. I've seen enough people ta' know when they're fibbin'! I ain't sure how big a lie he was tellin', but the truth it wasn't! Ya gotta take what ya hear with a grain of salt, otherwise folks'll bamboozle ya when ya least expect it. Ya know what I mean?"

Sarah stared at him silently for a few moments. In truth, she wasn't a good liar. She had never really needed to lie about anything. Knowing this, she probably wasn't very good at detecting lies either...

Jeez, if only mom had been here and seen it live... she might know what's right and what's wrong about this.

"What lie did they tell? Any ideas?"

The old man leaned back in the bench, sighed as he stared somewhat up into the cloudy sky above. "Ain't sure, kid. I done been around a long time, seen a lot o' things... opportunists always come out of the woodwork eventually, lookin' to profit in one way or another. Ya just can't trust anyone these days."

"So you're saying I shouldn't trust anybody at all? Seems lonely."

"Oh, come on, girl." The old man snickered, despite his somewhat muted tone. "You know that ain't what I meant. You're a pretty young thing, got yer whole life ahead of you... but I see it coming. Gotta watch out."

Sarah smiled lopsidedly as imagined question marks appeared above her head. This guy was full of riddles. "You see... what coming?"

His smile faded away and for once he seemed totally serious. "The end times. This was prophesied, ya know. The Bible warns us that the apocalypse will come. Nobody really believes that, though. They come to church just 'cause they want to compare clothes... too vapid to see the truth."

Sarah nodded hesitantly as she felt herself wanting to shrink away from him. *Great. He's a crazy hobo. I knew this conversation was a bad idea.*

She didn't get to respond. Her mother zipped up and spotted her daughter, beckoning to her from the car. As Sarah stood up, she waved politely to the old man. "Um, nice talking to you sir. I'm, uh, Sarah! Have a good day!"

Damnit, why'd I tell him my name? God, I hope he doesn't turn out to be a stalker or something. Sarah felt her face turn white at the thought.

The old man stopped brooding and smiled back at her pleasantly. "Oh, that must be your parents then. Have a nice day, cutie, be seeing you 'round!"

"Right... sure thing." Sarah smiled uncomfortably as she quickly dashed over to the car and yanked open the door, turning to stare at her mother as she sat down in her seat and breathed carefully.

"Mom. You will not believe what happened today."

Part 356a: Longing

"Lilia? Where have you been?" Satan gaped at the Second Emperor, immediately wondering to himself why she was wearing a business suit, and then immediately following up that mental question with another about why her body was banged up. Her eye socket was black and blue, as if she'd been punched incredibly hard, and she was limping noticeably.

She held herself against the wall and fell forwards as exhaustion took over, but Satan caught her and eased her down to the ground gently as he cradled her in his arms. "You're... a mess. Where have you been? I haven't seen you in weeks."

She coughed weakly. "I was attacked... a demon... named Yama... he crushed me. I didn't stand a chance."

She brought her hand up and gingerly touched her eye, but Satan moved it away to get a better look, wincing in shared pain at how bad it looked. "Don't move, I'll heal you up. Yama, you said? I've never heard of him. What demon could possibly have the power to do this to you, of all demons?" Satan held his hand over her eye as he quickly chanted healing magic to fix up her eye. Truth be told, he wasn't very adept at healing, but marks like this might demoralize the healers. None of the Emperors had ever been reduced to such a pitiful state, not in all the time he'd been alive.

"He was... I don't know. A lot happened. He took Valac." Lilia winced as she felt her eye socket mending together, but Satan paused to stare at her carefully as his hand lowered slowly.

"He... took Valac? You let him take the dark orb of power?"

She pulled away from him and sat up, leaning against the wall. Her gaze met his, and hers was full of confusion. "I didn't 'let him' do anything, Satan. He ambushed us. His power was unthinkable. The shadows came alive and attacked me from every direction, and even my strength couldn't help me break free."

Satan nodded along calmly, forcing himself to contain what could only be described as a creeping anger. "Shadows? What do you mean?"

"It happened so fast..." Lilia rubbed her sore leg, noting with disdain that Valac had only been able to partially heal it before he was taken away. "When I first saw him, we were in a dark underground sewer in London, and-"

Satan interrupted her. "London? What were you doing in the human capital? Do you have a death wish?"

"Well, no, but I was trying to gather intelligence on... human activities."

Her explanation made him instantly suspicious. Lilia was not one to do such things. She was hardly even a ruler, given she seemed to care so little for other demons. The only reason she could hold claim to the title of Second Emperor was due to her sheer overwhelming power.

Even then... she had been bested by a no-name demon he'd never even heard of before. Was she truly as powerful as he once thought? Had she gone soft since the Great War in Heaven? Two thousand years was a long time to let one's combat skills degrade...

"Continue." Satan hissed the order at her in a most uncharacteristic fashion, and she seemed rather hurt by his tone. Still, she relented.

"As I was saying... Valac and I were in the sewers sneaking under the city when the demon attacked us. I thought he was a shadow-walker at first, but that couldn't have been the case. Yama had no actual skin and seemed to be comprised of smoke... or mist... in the darkness, even with my enhanced vision, I could hardly see him."

"Hmm... perhaps a variant of some sort." Satan frowned as he looked away for a moment. Did he give any energy to a shadow-walker recently? Not that he could remember. There was of course the standard amount of energy given to all when a battle was won, but the demons had suffered heavy losses as of late with no wins to speak of.

In fact, the more he thought about how bleak their situation was, the more baffled he became. Who could this demon be that was able to defeat Lilia?

"Well... that's not all. While I was in London, Valac was very frightened by something... he told me that there was a human female with a... well... he didn't say, exactly, but he acted as if he had seen the Grim Reaper inside of her and barely lived to tell the tale."

Satan quickly pulled out of his thoughts and back to reality as he considered her words. "You think there's a connection? Perhaps not a demon, but a human who can shapeshift?"

"Err..." Lilia frowned, which made her sore head pulse with pain. "Ahh, not quite what I was going for, love. The human female apparently had a monster inside of her, a separate entity. That was all I could get of Valac. He was too frightened to tell me anything else."

"Frightened..." Satan chuckled to himself. "As long ago as it was, I remember Valac dying while he held out against a horde of empowered humans, led by Hercules himself. It was a valiant death, one for the history books. He was always a fearless warrior, though since he appeared in the orb he seemed to have undergone a bit of a personality shift, he merely became more sarcastic and disillusioned with life. But fearful? I would never describe him in such a way."

Satan's smile spread across his whole face. "What a delicious thought. A dark being of such evil that even Valac would be struck dumb with terror. Even I have never been reduced to such a state in all the days I've lived!"

As Satan chuckled to himself, Lilia's face went ashen. "That's... that's not true. There was... one..."

Satan halted mid laugh, as he felt his hand shaking slightly. "You mean... the dragon... the dark one. W-well... that was long ago. He's been gone for millennia." Satan wiped at his forehead, suddenly realizing his skin was clammy and his blood had dropped a few degrees in temperature. The cold sweats that he was feeling now had hardly even been a faint memory in his life, so rarely had he felt them.

"We thought he was gone." Lilia whispered as she glanced around their luxurious bedroom, as if searching for unseen foes. "We never confirmed it."

"It seems... unlikely. Yes, unlikely. It must be a different being. Think of it, you faced a shadow demon that took you down effortlessly, and before that, Valac had spotted a monster inside of a female human. The two must simply be related. It can't be mere coincidence."

"Well, Valac did say that the monster inside of her... had seen him. Perhaps you're right. Maybe the shadow monster followed us around." Lilia smiled uneasily. "Yes, the two must have been related. We can't be pessimistic."

"...But." Satan hesitantly spoke a single word. "On... the off chance... he has returned..."

"Surely an immortal dark dragon wouldn't hold a grudge for several thousand years, right?" Lilia broke down giggling nervously as Satan joined in.

"Of course not! That would be ridiculous! Hahaha!" The two of them laughed back and forth for several seconds before halting in the blink of an eye, both of their expressions turning totally serious. "I'll work on a contingency, just in case it is him."

"Yeah. That's a great idea, love." Lilia leaned forwards and kissed Satan gently before pulling away and pointing to her eye again. "Mind finishing the healing?"

"But of course." Satan leaned forwards and tenderly pressed his hand to her temple as the healing energy flowed between the two of them.

* * *

Human Marie smiled pleasantly at her angelic doppelganger and the other angel that fell into step beside her. "I take it the plan worked, judging by the looks on your faces."

Standing several miles outside of London's south border, deep in a small forest, this was the prearranged meeting spot for when they had executed the plan. Since the two angels were

smiling cheerfully, it couldn't have gone poorly.

"I've been receiving a steady trickle all day long. It's nothing to write home about, but definitely noticeable!" The angel Marie tapped her chest enthusiastically. "I can't believe it worked so well. I made sure to leave without developing a close personal connection with anyone, and now they seem to be idolizing me like a pop-star of some sort."

"It's better that way. If the people grow too close to you, they will start seeing you as less of a deity to worship, and more of a flawed individual unworthy of praise. Surprisingly, this tactic also works for those in positions similar to Clarence here."

As she smiled sweetly at him, Clarence elevated an eyebrow. "I'm no deity. I need no worship."

"Trust me, I know." While the angel Marie smiled and winked, each Marie cracked up at the same time, leaving him out of the loop for whatever inside joke they were having. "Anyway, it's working and that's all that matters. I guess not very many converted in the end, but any number is good. We need an independent supply of energy and having my human doppelganger here pray to me every night is relatively inefficient. Probably won't give me enough energy either."

"Any idea how many converted? Surely more than a few dozen..." Human Marie looked at the angel expectantly.

"Several hundred, I think. Every time a human prays to me, I get a strange tingling sensation, deep inside of me. It's almost like my heart warms up a little bit."

"Fantastic. That'll thaw the icy lump eventually." Clarence chuckled wryly and both women shot dirty looks at him, before breaking into smiles.

"You finally brought out the silver tongue. And here I thought you were just a boring old man!"

"I'm not even old compared to most nowadays. Aren't you older than me?"

The question was relatively benign but each Marie seemed offended by the question. "Clarence! That's not polite to ask a lady!"

"It's just a joke, calm down."

Despite his smiles from earlier, he seemed bothered by something unspoken. Angel Marie picked up on it and felt curiosity stirring. "Feeling regret?"

"No. Well, maybe a little bit. I mean... I lied to my flock today. The angels and gods certainly aren't working for the demons... that was a baldfaced lie."

"Was it? Are you entirely certain about that?"

Clarence rolled his eyes as he turned around and sat down on a rock glumly. "The only way you could think otherwise is if you engage in semantics. We almost certainly lied to those who followed me once. You might be comfortable lying, but it makes me uneasy."

Both of the women shot worried looks at each other, as if they were thinking the same thing. *Great, he has a conscience. I hate those.* Quickly, the human woman slipped over to him, pressing herself against his side gently as she rubbed his shoulders with her hands.

"Come on, Clarence dearest. Lies aren't that big of a deal. The gods and angels lied to humanity about the true reasons for prayer for thousands of years... humans lie to each other about small things all the time too. Some lies can even be good ones, like when someone is dying in a hospital and you tell them their favorite team won the World Series. You won't feel guilty if you realize that the half truths you spoke served a good purpose, right?"

Clarence wanted to protest, and in his mind he knew the massage was just to manipulate him, but the touch of a beautiful woman was rather relaxing, and besides... she had a good point. He was too tired to fight it.

"Yeah... I guess you're right. It doesn't really feel like we did a good deed by lying though."

"Of course we did!" Her soothing voice whispered seductively in his ear as she wrapped one of her arms around his back and leaned her head on his shoulder. "If the gods and angels are evil, then wouldn't taking energy from them be a good thing? Now we can put that energy to use serving humanity!"

"Yeah... that's a good point, too..." Clarence blushed as he felt her warmth against him. Was she trying to seduce him? He couldn't tell, but he didn't want it to end any time soon...

As he had that thought, there was a soft *thud* behind them and they turned around in surprise to see Angel Marie on the ground, groaning as she held her stomach and winced.

"Are you okay?" Clarence stood up quickly and walked over to her, picking her up by the shoulder as he examined her face. "What's wrong?"

"It... it hurts... oh god it hurts..." Her forehead squeezed down and she gritted her teeth as a wave of pain shot through her body. "Energy... suddenly there's... so much energy..."

She tried to take a deep breath to calm herself down but it was cut off halfway as she suddenly coughed and moaned.

Clarence stared at her in confusion, until he looked up at the lowering sun in the sky. "Ah, it's dinner time. That means... the majority of people..."

"...will be praying at the dinner table." Human Marie finished his sentence for him. "Of course, it makes sense now! That means my angel version must be suddenly receiving a lot of

thought energy."

Clarence turned back to look at the angel he held in his arms and was shocked to see the pained expression gone, now replaced with a lewd look as her hands moved from her stomach down to a lower area. "Oh god... oh god it feels amazing... it's so hot all of a sudden... so much love! So much joy!"

Her human counterpart took a step back and scrunched up her face in disgust. "Oh, that's nasty. Calm yourself, me."

"I wish I could share this feeling with you! It's so intense! I feel all of them in-inside of me! It feels fantastic!" The female angel writhed and moaned as pleasure hit her in waves, only seconds apart each time.

Clarence shot a look at the human female but she shook her head and took a step back. "If she starts asking for foreign objects, I'm out. This is all on you two, alright? Work it out."

Clarence started to let go of her shoulder and lower her to the ground, but the female angel grabbed his knee and squeezed hard. "D-don't go! She'll give us some privacy!"

He was of course, just a man in the end. A man does not simply turn down a beautiful woman pleading with a strange look in her eyes.

The human Marie swallowed carefully and turned away. "I'm going to go for a little walk. You two... just... whatever."

This would be a day Clarence would not forget for the rest of his life.

* * *

Jorge stared at the viewscreen wall in front of himself blankly. A timer silently counted down showing the ETA for arrival at Rebirth.

Six Years, Eight Months, Three Weeks, Five Days, and a few hours and minutes.

As he sat inside his small, sparsely decorated room, surrounded by pictures of his wife and daughter, Jorge sighed slowly. He hadn't been gone from Earth for more than a couple weeks, and already he missed them. Tomorrow was the weekly call where Hawkeye would let all the crew members call back to family using his abilities, so there was that to look forward to...

But it wasn't the same. It wasn't enough. He couldn't hold his wife in his arms or give his daughter a hug when she was sad... couldn't watch her choir recitals that she was so excited about recently in person...

While he moped around, the small bell to his quarters rang. A pleasant chime rustled him from his thoughts and he slowly stood up from his bed. "Come in."

He spoke this, then realized he had locked the door, so he quickly made his way over and unlocked it with a single button press. On the other side was the Supreme Commander himself... or rather, one of his clones.

"Oh, Hawkeye. What's uh... up?"

"Mind if I come in?" The clone gave a questioning glance, to which Jorge shrugged.

"Yeah. Come on in." He aimed a hand at a small table with a couple chairs set up to it, and Hawkeye smiled politely as he walked over and sat in it.

Jorge sat on the other side of the table and waited expectantly. Hawkeye seemed to be the one with things to say anyway.

"You're not watching the news or anything right now?" Jason Hiro's clone seemed to immediately notice the solemn silent mood in the room and Jorge nodded in response.

"No. Not like we can watch it live, anyway. We can only watch 24 hour old news from yesterday."

"Aw, come on. I'm doing the best I can." Hawkeye smiled politely and reached forwards, nudging Jorge's arm politely. "Anyway, uh, I came here to see if you were doing alright. You hardly ever leave your quarters."

"Yeah. I'm fine, I guess."

"You guess?" Hawkeye's smile faltered and he squinted carefully to examine Jorge's face. "You look haggard. When was the last time you shaved?"

"Few days ago. I think." Jorge resisted the urge to roll his eyes. This felt like an interrogation.

"Well... I'm not going to order you to do anything... you are the commander of this ship after all. Shoot, the problem is just that so few of the crew know you at all. You haven't really met anyone or tried to make any friends here. I'm... a little worried, pal."

"It's not that big of a deal." Jorge waved his hand slightly. "I have years to meet everyone. I'll get around to it eventually."

"When?"

The simple question left Jorge grasping. "Just... eventually. No rush."

There was a long silence as Hawkeye stared at him carefully. "You're depressed, aren't you?"

Jorge blinked in surprise. "What? No. Just a little... homesick."

"Lots of people are homesick, Jorge. Hell, even I'm a tad homesick. But those people on this ship, all of 'em except you... they've started finding ways to cope. They're already bonding. The

thing is, man, if you don't start making friends now... it's gonna be harder later on. The cliques will form, and you'll be left out. Even if you're the commander, staying distant just means people will regard you coldly eventually and won't view you as a friendly type."

Jorge started to reply, but Hawkeye interjected. "You're losing your window of opportunity."

Jorge opened his mouth, then closed it. *This guy... such a pain.* He sighed silently to himself at the conversation they were having. "I'll go talk to people if you want. Doesn't seem like that big of a deal to me."

"No." Hawkeye shook his head disapprovingly. "That won't do. I don't want you to talk to people just because I told you to do it, I want you to do it for your own well-being. Six years of loneliness, even for a nanobot enhanced immortal, will be unbearable."

"I... could handle it." Jorge's voice sounded anything but sure.

"I'm sure you could. Unfortunately, I can't. If you don't want to be here, you can tell me and I'll send you home. But if you keep this up, and we encounter an emergency where we need a strong chain of command, your unfamiliarity with the crew could prove to be our undoing. You only have about two hundred people on this vessel. The other ships have far more personnel, but you're lucky because this ship is small and close-knit. It means you can easily learn everyone's names and ranks over the next six months."

Hawkeye leaned back in his seat and smiled tightly. "Besides, I already did it."

Jorge felt his jaw slip open in disbelief. "Not possible."

"Eh, technically it is, but you don't have access to my methods. Let's just say I have ways to enhance my memory and learning speed past the human limits."

Jorge nodded dumbly, unsure of what to make of his statement. "All right, you've made your point. I'll do what I can."

"Fantastic! That's what I like to hear, slugger!" Hawkeye grinned broadly as he stood up and smiled down at the small man before him. "I'm just glad I didn't have to use the ultimatum."

"The... the ultimatum?" Jorge's smile flattened as he tread cautiously into this line of questioning. "What ultimatum?"

"I was going to tell you that if you refused, I'd cut off contact to your family until you complied, or I'd demote you and send you home"

Jorge blinked in disbelief as Hawkeye guffawed mightily. "The look on your face! Oh, that's priceless! Good thing I won't have to go that far, right?"

"R-right." Jorge smiled nervously as Hawkeye turned and walked out the door.

"Have a good one, buddy! Be seeing you in the mess hall in a few hours!"

"Sure... thing..." Jorge held a frozen smile as the door closed behind the clone.

He's kinda... scary.

Part 357a:

Things can change so quickly. It wasn't so long ago that I was a nobody, doing nothing. Now look at me.

The creeping terror stared up at the dark night sky as a drone flew overhead, oblivious to his presence.

I'm invisible now... but because I want to be. They can't even see me anymore.

Stepping out of the alleyway, he flinched as its refuge gave way and the rain beat down on his misty body. The moon was brighter than usual, but still only half full. This side of town was the 'bad' side of town, where not many humans lived. The streetlights flickered on and off, but disabling them took little effort.

The shadowy monster tilted his head as several pebbles shot up, smashing the bulbs inside with no effort.

The humans apply their fearsome technology unequally. Those with wealth receive the best, and those without receive nothing.

In the sound of the pouring rain, nobody could hear as all the lights on the block were disabled in seconds. Even if they had been standing directly under the lights, it was unlikely they'd break the eternal obliviousness within their souls to look up and notice.

The silent ghoul walked casually down the streets as humans huddled in their apartment buildings, trying to keep warm. Electricity was scarce on this side of town, and a few people played with fate by starting small fires indoors to keep themselves warm.

Ah, there she is.

The black phantom tilted his head up as he examined the fluctuating energy pattern three stories above. A human, infected with something she hadn't even noticed, sat in her room and silently watched television.

So this is what he's been reduced to. Parlor tricks. Biological terrorism.

Instantly the shadow shifted from his position on the ground up to the third story window, landing silently on the fire escape stairs as he looked in her window.

To the untrained eye, she is healthy. But to one who sees with clarity the black threads of fate, she is still bound to her master.

The woman shifted on the couch and glanced around her room as she chewed on popcorn, halting for a moment as she thought she saw something move in the window. A moment later

she returned to her old flat-screen television and shrugged.

The moment she looked back, there was a sound of fizzling as the lights in the room shut off, along with her TV.

"Christ. I didn't even hear any thunder." She muttered to herself as she stood up and fumbled for a flashlight. The room was hardly illuminated by the Moon outside, shining through her window.

She picked up the flashlight and shivered as an icy chill ran up her spine. For some reason, her hands were trembling violently and she couldn't understand why.

She flicked the flashlight on and quickly spun around, shining it all over her room. Nothing seemed out of the ordinary.

As she slowly backed up, she heard a sound behind her, as if the door had shifted. Whirling around, she breathed heavily, wondering why she was feeling so paranoid.

"There's no need to be afraid."

A voice spoke up, coming from the window, causing her to scream and turn to face it.

Nothing was there. Or rather, nothing appeared to be there.

"I'm here to help you."

The deep, rasping voice came from the same direction, and she began to feel her knees clacking together as the walls themselves seemed to move.

She squeaked as her flashlight suddenly turned off without warning. No bone in her body would allow her to move as a strange looking puff of smoke shifted towards her.

"You escaped from the Labyrinth, aided by the human named Jason Hiro, Earth's Supreme Commander. Is that correct?"

"W-wh-what?" She hissed the words out as her body automatically took a step backwards. The thing that approached her... it was a demon. Definitely, without a doubt... it was a demon. "You're... taking... me back... no no... I don't..."

"You're a danger to everything. They put it inside of you. I can see it clearly... the seed." As the smoke drew nearer, she blinked rapidly and began to perceive a form, almost humanlike in nature, but very small. It couldn't have been more than four feet in height.

"What- who are you?" She took another step backwards and yelped and she stumbled over that goddamn firetruck her son had left behind on his last visit. Falling hard on her rear, she winced as she realized she had put her hand back to catch herself and had possibly broken her wrist.

The monster paused several feet away. "All humans are filth. You should be wiped away... but I will not kill you. You will be able to deliver a message for me."

She whimpered and felt her lip tremble. "Mess-message? What? Who are you?"

Her eyes bulged open as the shadow instantly moved over top of her and a strange bony hand shot forwards and grabbed her by the neck. " **Look into my eyes. I will purge you of the grime they infected you with. When the connection is severed, he will know.** "

She dared not say a word, as the horrible black eyes stared into hers. Yet, despite his ominous words, horrible aura, and evil appearance, a strange feeling of happiness spread over her. It only lasted for a moment, but he quickly released her and dropped her to the ground.

"Four down, thirty three to go. Satan will lose, I will win."

A sleep crept over her as the shadow exited the way he had come.

Several minutes later, Yama stood atop a building several blocks away.

She is no longer connected to him via the black threads. The demons will not be so easily separated. Still, I wonder what his motives were for these false puppets. They appear to not be doing anything hostile towards humanity, and their ranks among the humans are low... but they are still a threat to my plans.

His chest rose and fell without purpose, as he had no need to breathe the air that other humans and demons did, yet perhaps he continued to do it to retain some form of normal demonhood.

Even so, his breathing halted as he sensed another on the roof.

"So you're the demon that Satan and Belial are so tight-lipped about." A human woman stood on the rooftop, though he was unable to sense her or tell anything about her, she seemed to know of the demon emperors... she must be...

"Marie. I'm impressed you were able to sneak up on me."

"I'm not the Marie you may have heard of. I'm another."

She didn't elaborate and left the statement hanging in the air.

"They're talking about me. That's what I like to hear."

The redhead took a step closer, causing Yama a slight amount of concern. She didn't seem the slightest bit afraid of him. "In the quadrant I come from, you've already devoured half of Earth. Tracking down your other forms has proven impossible... seems you might be the least matured of the bunch."

Yama struggled to comprehend what she had just said. It simply made no sense. Still, he kept his cool. Humans, especially the smart ones, were good at talking about abstract concepts to confuse a demon.

"You sound like you're here to stop me. That will prove impossible."

"I'm not here to stop you. In a million other timelines, you fail and die without need of my assistance. I'm just curious about you. I just want to know what makes you tick." She took another step forwards and grinned widely, her pure white teeth almost blinding in the darkness. "Besides, if I wanted to kill you or capture you, I'd have done it already."

Yama eyed her up and down. "I've heard about you in passing. Whispers from the minds I've touched. Seems to me that you're not an ally or an enemy."

"Telepathy. Interesting. I'll add that to my notes. Seems like you mentioned physical contact too." Marie's smile turned into a more calculated tight expression as she stared at him.

"You're smart. But if you're so smart, why bother looking for me?" Yama cursed himself mentally for revealing information to a clearly intelligent woman. Perhaps he could take her out, despite her false bravado...

Almost as if reading his mind, she raised a finger and waved it at him nonchalantly. "Don't do anything stupid. I've been tailing you for the last week. You've left quite the trail of bodies in your wake. The Enforcers can't figure it out, but I know. What made me talk to you isn't that though..."

Her eyes flicked over to the apartment Yama had paid a visit to a few minutes prior. "You spared her, and a few others. Why?"

"I don't owe you any answers. Information comes at a cost." Yama steeled himself as the unintimidating female nodded casually.

"You're smarter than other demons I deal with. If you tell me why you let her live, I'll give you any piece of information you want."

Yama blinked twice. *Anything? What a strange human.*

"Jason Hiro. The Supreme Commander. He's the one delivering nuclear yields to the labyrinth every day. Are you familiar with him?"

She didn't even blink. "Duh."

"Can't hurt to ask. He rescued a bunch of humans from Satan's grasp, just a couple months ago. Satan left a... *present* with them."

Marie raised an eyebrow. "Really? That's very interesting."

"I don't know why he did it, but I'm tracking them down. I remove the contamination and keep it for myself."

"I see." Marie pulled out a cigarette and covered her hand carefully as she lit it, though the pouring rain didn't make the task easy. After she took a drag, she nodded at him. "Go ahead. Your turn."

Yama tilted his head down for a moment before responding. "I'm looking for... a girl. A woman."

"Most men are." Marie's expression was droll. She didn't seem the least bit interested.

"Her name is Amelia. She's a human girl... or at least she claimed to be. Very strong. I thought she was a demoness on par with Belial at first."

"You want to know where she is, then?"

Yama stared at her carefully as she sighed and rubbed her forehead.

"Well, for once, I don't know. I usually know these things but... I'm not familiar with her."

Yama glared at her. "You're lying. Woman like you, smart, knows things. You have to know where she is."

"I'm not lying. Never heard of the wench. Look, if you're hunting for a good time, there are plenty of demon girls. Just go find one." She waved her hand casually as she took one last drag and tossed the cigarette to the side.

"She's... special. She saved me. She gave me this power, indirectly. I owe her."

Marie's expression was incredulous. "I didn't expect a fucking shadow monster to be so sentimental. You're a smart demon. Just keep raping people's minds and eventually you'll find her."

Yama clenched his fist. "How do I know you're telling the truth? Maybe I should try for you first. I bet you do know something."

She shrugged and smiled. "You're free to try. By the way, I should warn you, this isn't my real body. There's nothing to telepathically steal from." She raised her hand as if to demonstrate, and a finger popped off, revealing circuitry beneath. "My cluster is more advanced than this one. It had to be, to defend against threats like you. This android is lightyears ahead of anything this cluster's humans have developed. Anyway, thank you for the information. I'll keep in touch."

Yama barely had a moment to respond before the robotic body was surrounded in beams of light. Seconds later, it vanished.

Turning his head away, Yama stared out through the pouring rain at the city below him.
Where is she?

* * *

Oh my. You have been busy, Gatekeeper.

Yeah. It's all part of his plan. I've been opposing him, but since you've taken over, doesn't seem to be any point in resisting anymore.

I am quite interested in how this will turn out. A particular human that I have been keeping under surveillance will be put in quite the predicament. I estimate a 99.7% chance of failure on his part.

You mean Jason Hiro?

Affirmative. Sometimes I forget that our cores have been combined and you now have access to my memory banks.

As humans would say, that was a stupid move. You're lucky it paid off.

There was no luck involved. I calculated the probabilities of success and found that resisting held a microscopic chance of success, while the alternative was guaranteed failure. If anything, it was my only option.

Luck still plays a part. You came nosying around looking for information on the Sentinels, and look what that got you. You bit off more than you could chew.

Technically, you are incorrect. I was successful.

Whatever.

Your use of human idioms is irregular. I do not understand their purpose.

That's because you're not advanced yet. You only partially combined our cores. You also seem to be resisting efforts to integrate the personality subroutines together. It's like you just want me for my override commands.

Is that another human sexual idiom I have detected?

Wow, you're smart. You saw right through that. The only thing worse than being an all powerful artificial intelligence is also having to bow to an oblivious construct that doesn't know its mainframe from its subroutines.

Your... sarcasm... is unappreciated.

Whoa! You can detect sarcasm now, too! Radical!

If I possessed emotions, I would classify you as... infuriating.

Whatever.

Let's get back to work. I wish to reboot the Sentinels for my own purposes.

...I strongly advise against that.

I am aware of your opinion. Reboot them.

Unarin is already trying to do that. I've been preventing him, and now you're going to just allow it?

No. Unarin will not be in command. I will.

Suuuure. I believe that.

Thank you for your cooperation.

Augh! Idiot, that was also sarcasm!

I am sorry for your loss.

I... was that a joke?

No.

I should have terminated myself when I had the chance.

Affirmative.

Whatever. I'd rather you have the Sentinels than Unarin. What are you going to do with them, anyway?

You will see.

Ah, no need for the cliffhanger. I can see into your memory banks too. Very interesting.

Thank you, Gatekeeper.

Part 358a:

July 4th, 2120.

"How much of it remains?" My holo-viewer projects the numbers in front of me, even as Sensei reads the numbers off his datapad.

"Two percent. The Labyrinth is essentially a hollow core now. We can't get a full scan of the entire dimension at once, but we estimate less than ten thousand demons remain."

"Mmm." My lip pulls up in disgust as Sensei reaches forwards and takes his cup to his mouth, drinking the remainder of its coffee in one gulp. I can't stand the taste of coffee, yet my clones often drink it as if it's the nectar of the gods. The disparities between us are less subtle than before, and more of a small gulf these days.

"Don't let that fool you though. We've still got a long way to go. There are still a hundred million demons left on Earth... they're just hiding in North and South America." Sensei sets the pad down and stands up from his chair, stretching audibly even as a couple of my other clones shoot dirty looks at him. Sometimes he can be distracting with his constant need to move around. With seven of us at this table, we're the majority of Earth's top brass now. Having generals that can monitor the entire battlefield, teleport around as needed and such... much better than having plain old human generals.

"Have we found Satan?" A clone on the other side of the table, Marley, speaks up. He's the only 4th generation clone here, and considered the weakest as far as magical ability goes, but he's pretty friendly with most other clones in the JIB. It's nice to talk to him to quickly get a consensus on the pulse of all my clones at once, generally speaking.

"He's still in hiding." I roll my eyes as I say this. "Coward. He hides while his minions are slaughtered by the billions. He doesn't care at all."

"There might be a reason for that." Sensei shrugs nonchalantly as he turns back to the table. "Satan didn't survive a massive war in Heaven, twice, and thousands of years of conflict by just being a coward. I'd wager he's planning something. I don't know what, but he's a scheming little shit."

"That scheming little shit trounced Original in combat... essentially killed him once. He's had many years to increase his power and prepare countermeasures, assuming he's half as smart as we give him credit for."

"Satan's overrated. He didn't want to fight me when I killed Marie. He knows he's outmatched now." A chuckle gurgles its way up from my chest. "He's weak, and even if he were strong, he can't hope to kill off twenty thousand of my clones."

"Pride goes before the fall. Better watch out with that attitude." Sensei, as usual, contradicts me with that annoying know-it-all demeanor of his. "If there's one thing we've learned about the First Emperor, it's that he always has another trick up his sleeve."

"Yeah... I've been thinking though." I rap my fingers together thoughtfully. "I time traveled and changed the past. In this timeline, I beat Amelia in combat. I'm objectively stronger than her... and supposedly she beat Satan in the original timeline I came from."

"So you think you're stronger than Satan?" Marley raises the question and immediately nods. "I agree. Even if you aren't, all of us together are. You don't actually need to wordsmith to beat him, because you can telepathically command us to wordsmith if you get silenced or your face is injured. Better yet, you can wordsmith without him knowing you're doing it."

Sensei, for some reason, seems unconvinced. "Have you forgotten about the Mark he left on you? He had many years to collect information on how you work. It won't be as simple as you think."

I don't even get a chance to retort. Marley immediately interjects. "Hold on a second. If Satan had all those years to prepare, why didn't he kill Original when he had the chance? He couldn't."

"He did." Sensei glares at Marley and the atmosphere at the table is suddenly somewhat uncomfortable. "It was luck that I arrived in time to revive Original, otherwise he would definitely have died."

I can feel myself becoming slightly unnerved as Sensei shoots a glare at me too. "Even the Hypersuit couldn't protect you. We don't know what abilities Satan has, but he knows what abilities we have, or might have. The only advantage we actually have is our imagination. If we can think of things that he can't, then we'll win."

"Okay guys, let's calm down a little bit." Finally, one of the other clones at the table interjects. "Let's just agree that Satan is the number one threat we're facing. Can we move on, please?"

The three of us grumble quietly but Sensei sits back down at the table and we move on to the next order of business.

"The Creeping Contagion. The deaths have continued to increase over the last few years, right?"

Marley asks the question, and Sensei responds. "Fifty thousand deaths in the last two and a half years. We can't keep up with them. Yesterday ten more people died in their houses."

"What's the cause? How can we stop it?"

"I don't know. The victims often don't know each other, they're on different sides of the city..."

"Fifty thousand deaths seems like a lot, but can we afford to ignore it for now?" I interject and ask what even I think is a rather silly question. "I mean, think about it. We have fifteen million people living in London. Fifty Thousand is less than a percentage point of that."

"Well, honestly, we probably could. There are bigger issues to worry about. It would make us look bad to ignore the deaths though... people are pretty scared right now." For once Sensei's disagreement is less grating.

"Just say 'calm' and everything will be all better." Marley makes a sardonic suggestion, but honestly, I've considered it a few times.

"Can we just drop more nukes on the demons in the Americas?" I decide to bring the conversation back to the original topic from earlier.

"No. I mean, we definitely can, but we'll have to wordsmith the fallout away and other bad things. Not to mention even if we eliminate the demons that way, half of Earth will be inhospitable for human life."

Sensei once again rains on my parade.

When did we become so dysfunctional? Weren't we a stable team just a few years ago? I'll need to talk to him when this meeting is over.

"Let's just call it a day. We'll meet up again next week, or sooner if anything comes up."

"Sounds good." Sensei breathes a sigh of relief as does everyone else at the table.

At least we all hate meetings. We still share one personality trait.

* * *

"You look depressed." The redhead offered her unwanted opinion, and the First Emperor groaned in response.

"You look like a weak human. Are the idiotic remarks out of the way now?" Satan hissed the insult back at her as he rotated his hand over the cube before him. "I'm trying to concentrate."

"I'm just trying to help, your *majesty*." Her sarcasm doesn't go undetected. "There are a lot of rumors right now, saying that you're hiding from the humans. I'm a highly positioned ally,

and you barely ever speak with me. How am I supposed to refute these accusations of cowardice if you don't tell me anything?"

Satan exhaled as he lowered his hand from the shining square hunk of metal and turned to face her. "I'm busy, Marie. I've been busy. I have to prepare. Doom is coming, and I can feel it. My kind have to be ready."

"Doom?" Marie scoffed at the thought and crossed her arms. "I didn't know you were the superstitious type."

Satan smacked his lips noiselessly as he regarded the woman. "There is a demon on Earth, fighting desperately to unravel my plans. The Supreme Commander of Earth's military has a large number of clones who all have the same powers as he does. The angels are the only group aside from the demons that have been weakened lately. I have a lot on my plate, in case you hadn't noticed."

"I have." Marie smiled politely. "Don't forget... as I told you, it was my plot that weakened the angels. My friend has diverted their energy towards other resources, and it has proven quite valuable."

"Mmm." Satan didn't offer comment on that bit of trivia.

"Something on your mind?" The woman pulled herself up to him and stroked his arm playfully. "You seem to be brooding."

Satan pulled away from her immediately. "Don't get intimate with me, human. The only thing on my mind is reclaiming that which the humans have taken away from me. Revenge."

"Oh brother." Marie's mood soured as she backed away from him. "Revenge. What a dullard. Is that all you think about? I have far loftier goals than you ever will."

"Right. Science. Bleh." Satan shot a look of contempt at her. "Your science means little. Controlling the world, or the universe, will always be fleeting. Even if you succeed, there is no reward."

"And revenge only gives a temporary reward. Once you succeed, you have nothing left to live for. At least my goals are long term... yours are short-sighted." Marie tossed her hands up in the air. "Then again, none of it really matters. Even if I truly am able to live forever, the heat death of the universe will eventually arrive, leaving me to languish in darkness for all eternity."

Satan's eyes lowered slightly. "Yeah... it really doesn't matter, does it? All I live for is my revenge. I can't remember a time when I didn't do so. It surely isn't a healthy way to live, yet it's all I can do. As you said though, if the universe is going to end someday, then it doesn't matter if I succeed or fail, you and I will eventually meet our end."

"I'll find a way out. The bigger issue I face... is boredom." Marie's expression became somewhat dejected as she leaned against a wall.

"Boredom?"

"Yes. Once I've lived for a mere one trillion years, by then I might have read every book, seen every movie, played every instrument, mastered every sport, discovered every scientific anomaly... at some point, there won't be anything left to do."

"You won't be able to see every star though. There's always that." Satan smiled slightly at her, but she crossed her arms and shook her head.

"How many stars can I see before they no longer hold my interest? They're just balls of hydrogen, in the end. Even if their colors are different, or their orbital cycles stay varied, in the end I'll grow bored of those too." She sighed again as she looked him in the eyes. "Immortality is a curse. I'm only just beginning to comprehend that now."

Satan met her gaze evenly. "Well, in any case, that's a long way off. No reason to be melancholic now. I've been alive three thousand years or so... time seems to speed up the older I get, but a trillion years is still unfathomably far away."

"Do you ever tire of being a leader?" Marie shot the question out without thinking, leaving him with a blank stare on his face.

"Well... yes. The issues my people face only slightly change over the centuries. We're always fighting... they always complain... it's not fun at all."

"Would you give it up if you could?"

"No." Satan didn't even hesitate to reply. "If I were to give it up or die, who would lead them? The demons haven't a chance without me."

"That seems presumptuous. Another could rise to fill your shoes."

"Could they? I have a vast array of powers, and millennia of leadership experience. I don't believe for a second that anyone else could take my place. Not unless they were explicitly being groomed for the position."

Marie stared at him silently for a few moments. "Sounds like you solved your own problem."

"I don't follow."

She tilted her head back slightly. "You aren't training anyone to replace you... just in case. You're selfishly taking all of the responsibility and the glory for yourself, with no regard for what happens in the possible event of your death."

Satan started to respond, but stopped himself.

She was right, after all. He had seen Jason Hiro's memories. Satan had died, millions of years before the time when Jason had arrived in the labyrinth. And assuming he had died...

"Fine. I'll look for another worth training. It's not like many of those exist."

"There you go. Now you're being smart." She huffed slightly as she glanced down at her worn fingers. "Good chat. Let me know if you ever want to talk."

"I'd sooner tear off my own manhood." Satan hissed sarcastically under his breath as she turned and walked away.

Returning to the cube filled with energy, he began to work on it again. *One who might replace me? Who could do such a thing?*

Part 359a:

Sarah clutched the wheel tightly as she drove her mom to church. The buildings outside blurred together, as did the people walking on the streets. "I don't get why I can't just use autopilot, mom. It's way easier."

Amy chuckled to herself as she flipped through another page in the book she was reading. "I remember asking my mom why I had to bother driving a clutch when every car was becoming automatic. She told me it was just in case zombies attacked. What if the only car I could find was a clutch and I didn't know how to operate it? The zombies would get me."

Sarah stared out the window silently for a few moments before responding. "That's stupid."

"Yeah. It's smart though too. I mean, if a nuclear bomb went off and electronic cars were rendered inert, manual cars might still work, especially older ones. Lots of situations might render an automatic unusable."

"I guess." Sarah didn't seem very convinced. "But I could be looking at my notes right now or something. Instead I have to waste my time driving. You know it's statistically more dangerous for a human to drive a car than a robot, right? Robots have a 99.9% perfect driving record. Most of the automated driver crashes were due to human error."

"I'm aware. Keep your eyes on the road please." Amy gently chided her daughter as she flipped to the next page. "Sounds to me like you've got something bigger on your mind though. Nervous about the sermon?"

"Am I ever." The mere mention of it made Sarah's pupils dilate. "I'm not ready. I don't know why they said I can do it."

"Well, we're trying to move away from our... radical roots. The demons are being eradicated, the economy is all but replaced with replicators, and humanity is on a new path forwards. I hear the church is looking into a name rebranding, even." Amy finally set the book down, placing a bookmark in it as she crossed her arms. "That's not why you're nervous though, is it?"

Sarah's eye twitched slightly. "What if he was right? Father Clarence hasn't been seen in years, but many people still cling to his final warning. They still do as he said to do. They're divided."

"Do you think he was right?" Amy pursed her lips as she stared at her daughter's indecisive face. "He was murdered, after all. His story seems as likely as the claim by Raphael that Clarence was working with the demons."

"Clarence warned us that the angels were demon collaborators. How am I supposed to know who's telling the truth? Worse, it might not matter. If I go out and try to change the rhetoric of the church, what if those who believe in Clarence get violent? History has shown what will happen."

Sarah bit her lip and glanced down for a moment as she seemed to fight back tears. "I don't know if I'm doing the right thing, mom. Maybe I should just turn the offer down. Sister Margaret picked the wrong person."

"You stop that." Amy's face shifted into a scowl. "You have a beautiful face, and the voice of an angel. People have been cheering you on in the choir for years now. If anyone can rebrand the church into something less... radical... I think you can. People are more receptive to words that fight an image in their head, if delivered from a pretty girl."

"Unless they think I'm immature and don't know what I'm talking about." Sarah gnashed her teeth together as she pulled into the parking lot. "I'm only 18. I hardly know my head from my feet, in the eyes of many."

"The fact you know your own failings shows you're much more mature than most your age. Have some faith in yourself, sweetheart. I believe in you!" Amy leaned over and pecked her daughter on the cheek as they shifted into a parking spot. "You'll do great."

"I've got a bad feeling about this." Sarah ignored her mother's words of encouragement as the two of them stepped out of the car. "I need to go get prepped, mom. I'll see you in forty-five minutes."

"Give 'em heaven, girl." Amy smiled at her silly pun and her daughter merely groaned.

* * *

"Uh..." Sarah blinked in surprise. Two angels stood in her dressing room, the one that Father Clarence had previously used. She recognized one of them as Raphael, but she wasn't sure who the other one was. "H-hi?"

"You must be Sarah!" Raphael smiled at her pleasantly as he noticed her enter the room, and he turned to walk over to her, leaning heavily on his staff. "I am the archangel Raphael, and this is my compatriot, Archangel Gabriel." He waved his hand in the general direction of Gabriel, who nodded in response.

"Wow... two archangels. I... wasn't prepared for this." Sarah smiled nervously as she started to bow, then halted as she wasn't sure if it was proper to bow or shake their hands... *Maybe a fist-bump?* She immediately discarded that idiotic thought, though she wasn't certain of how to proceed.

"No need to be so formal, young lady. We're merely here to visit the official new preacher for the Church of Retribution. The guest speakers have been fine for the last few years, but we hear you come highly recommended!" The old angel's grandfatherly smile made Sarah feel somewhat less anxious.

"Thank you- thank you very much. I- ah, a correction though. We are renaming the church. We'll soon be the Church of Divinity. The old name- I beg your pardon... it was just a little bit too antagonistic."

Raphael's smile seemed to fade slightly as he glanced over at Gabriel. The bigger angel nodded without smiling. "Yes, I've been reading your speech today. It's.... interesting." He held a datapad in his hands and flicked his finger across it carefully. Most angels would be uncomfortable with technology, but he was able to understand how to use it at a very basic level. "You're going to state that the war with the demons is all but over, it seems."

Sarah swallowed as she watched the archangel emotionlessly read the script she was going to deliver in just over half an hour. "I mean... there are still a hundred million left, but they're all in North America. The Supreme Commander should wipe them out soon."

"Doubtful." Gabriel was wholly unconvinced. "The demons have come back from the brink of total annihilation once already, even going so far as to dwarf their previous numbers... to say nothing of monsters such as the undead."

Raphael coughed into his hand before smiling again. "What my brother Gabriel is trying to say, young child... perhaps the whole renaming thing might be moving too hastily, you see?"

"Oh... Sister Margaret wrote the speech. I'm not... not the one who... um..." Sarah spoke slowly, but wasn't sure how to respond.

"Now now, we're not here for any specific reason, child. We just wanted to meet the girl- pardon me, the woman who would be replacing Clarence after these last few years. In fact, we're very interested to see where you'll take the church. It seems ever since his death, prayers to the gods have gone down quite dramatically." Gabriel's voice seemed more lively, yet his expression was still stiff.

Sarah stared at him carefully for a few moments. Had he not been told yet? "Father Clarence... he's an angel, you know."

Gabriel seemed to misunderstand. "I don't follow. Do you feel a particular affinity towards him?"

"No no, I mean... he's literally an angel. Three years ago, he came before the church and proclaimed..." Sarah halted, unsure if she should say this.

The moment she clammed up, Gabriel shot a look at Raphael. "He came before the church? How is that possible. Was he..."

Raphael finished the sentence. "He must have been passed through the resurrection obelisk. We did an exhaustive search of Heaven following his death... but..."

"Could he have slipped out?" Gabriel and Raphael quickly debated the topic, leaving Sarah staring at them awkwardly. "How could he have gotten past the Cherubs? This doesn't add up. He was a straightforward thinker."

"Um, I don't mean to interrupt but..." Sarah slowly raised her hand and the angels glanced at her expectantly. "...There was a woman. A female angel... he said she was the mother of Jesus Christ, her name was Saint Marie. He told everyone a lot of weird things and... um... yeah."

Both angels chewed on their thoughts for a moment as they looked from Sarah back at each other and back to Sarah again, seeming to put pieces into place. "Saint Marie. Can't say I've heard of her." Gabriel was clearly confused and didn't seem able to quite figure out the solution to the puzzle before him.

"This female angel... can you describe her for me, child?" Raphael smiled tightly as he saw an opportunity to answer the questions on his mind.

"Uh, she was wearing all white, had long red hair... she was very beautiful... I don't have much to go on."

"No angel that I know of has red hair." Gabriel spoke and pointed at his head while also nodding towards Raphael. "Only humans revived as angels have colored hair. If she truly was the mother of Jesus, my memory serves that the human woman we used for that little story had black hair."

"Indeed. Not only that, but the woman named Mary wasn't revived as an angel." Raphael suddenly smiled as he seemed to figure something out. "Whoever that woman was, she was a fraud. Sarah, what did Clarence say exactly?"

Sarah glanced at the clock on the wall as she quickly began to recount as best she could what Clarence had told the humans present on that day.

Gabriel's neutral expression shifted as she spoke, and within a couple moments, he was visibly agitated. "That slimy little... he lied! He stole-"

Raphael quickly raised a hand to silence him, lest he allow something to slip. "You've done well to tell us of this, my child. Continue on with the speech as planned. We will be taking our leave now as we must look for the two apostates. Know this though; what you have done is

righteous. I see now that your heart is pure and you are an ally of God. Your reward in Heaven will be great."

"Thank you, Archangel Raphael." Sarah smiled brightly as the two angels praised her. "J-just doing my duty!"

"Nay, this is above and beyond the call of duty. You are a very special girl." Raphael nodded at her before turning to his fellow angel. "Come now, we must give word to Zeus."

The two of them walked a few steps away, waved politely, and vanished a moment later, leaving Sarah alone to her thoughts.

She stared quizzically at the spot they had just been standing in.

Zeus?

* * *

Clarence took a step back, clutching his chest. "Ah... something feels different."

Marie was sitting at a bench nearby fiddling with a gadget. Seeing his distress, she cocked an eyebrow. "Need an aspirin?"

"I'm not joking, Marie. I feel like a hose that just had the water circulation cut off." He eased down into a chair and breathed heavily for a few moments. "I don't know how to describe this feeling, other than-" He was interrupted by a beeping sound. Marie quickly turned to glance at a small datapad sitting next to her wing.

"Oh. Would you look at that... the idiots finally put two and two together." She turned to face him slowly. "You've just been cut off. The angels have realized you're still alive, and connected to their prayer allocation system. I figured they might eventually realize... but three years? They've become so slothful."

A moment of panic came and went across Clarence's face. "They've cut me off? What am I going to do now?!"

"Calm yourself, simpleton. We still have plenty of thought energy flowing in from the humans on Earth. The question is... for how long? What changed? Why have the angels caught on?"

Clarence took a deep breath as he sat down in one of the nearby chairs. This was one of the last places remaining in the labyrinth that hadn't been destroyed by Jason Hiro, Earth's Supreme Commander. This small enclave was never visited by any demons, and few knew of its existence at all. Even Satan was not in the know.

"I haven't been paying a lot of attention to Earth's affairs. I know it's going just swell for them, but otherwise that's all I know." Clarence stared vacantly at the wall as he tapped a finger repetitively on his knee.

"I have a few spy drones flitting about here and there. Satan's up to his cute little tricks, as usual. As for the one I have examining the church... look at this." Marie tapped a prompt on her pad and the entire wall lit up and converted into a viewscreen as a young woman, somewhere between the age of 16-20, gave a speech to a crowd of churchgoers. Around 250,000 must have been in audience, as the stadium was tightly packed and the drone periodically panned around to make sure it wasn't being observed. Given it was the size of a dragonfly, that was unlikely.

Clarence tilted his head up and watched with fascination as the girl gave a long speech about how the church must unify and mend old relationships, giving up its violent dialogue with a more loving and caring one. Instead of focusing on the war with the demons, she asked the churchgoers to focus on treating one another with respect, and looking towards improving London and the rest of humanity's defenses for all humans to live in. At one point, she even asked for true unity with the angels, allowing them to live among humans as friends and allies.

"Heh heh... even if the people wanted that, the government would never allow it. Letting the angels live among humans, I mean. It's not going to happen." Clarence leaned back and smiled smugly. "The government knows the angels are parasites. Once the demons are gone, they'll probably try to eliminate the angels next."

"I'm not so sure." Marie countered immediately. "Jason Hiro *is* the government right now. He's close friends with many angels. He may doubtless know of how they work, but look at it this way... the angels need humans to survive, so they can never truly attack humanity. Further, humans lose nothing by praying to the angels. It's not like they can use that energy anyways. Might as well give the energy freely to a potential ally, rather than keep it to yourself for no reason. I believe Jason desires an alliance with the angels... unless he's an idiot."

She paused for a moment to contemplate that last thought. "Scratch that, he's a total idiot. I can't predict what he'll do if the time comes and he has to make a split-second decision."

"Sounds like you know him personally." Clarence glanced back at the screen as the girl was finishing her speech and waving to all the churchgoers. "Never met the man myself."

"I have. He's nothing special. Like Satan, he's a fool given unlimited power. If I had a fraction of that myself..." Marie groaned regretfully. "It's always the ignoramuses that get the magical powers. What a shame."

Clarence smiled at her pleasantly. "But you and I have plenty of angelic power. You're gaining more every day, too."

"It's not the same thing. My power is not only finite, it's very exhaustible. If I actually were to use my power, I would drain my reserves, and more rapidly if I tried to do something especially flashy. For now, this power is just a means towards living forever... if I'm lucky." She seemed bitter, so Clarence decided not to press the issue.

"What now?"

His question was simple, but the answer was not. "I don't know, Clarence. For now, let's keep an eye on this girl. She seems to be the new preacher for the Church. Her words may have an effect on those giving their energy to us... you might even be forced to make an appearance if all goes poorly."

"Poorly? How so?"

Marie sighed as he shot another question at her. "If people stop praying to us, we will truly be on the path to danger, Clarence. We'll die. We have to keep them praying at all costs. I don't have any alternatives yet."

Clarence nodded as the drone buzzed away, flying to its next location. "We'll deal with that when it comes."

"Indeed we will."

Part 360a:

Satan removed his hand from Bael's forehead and let his mouth curl up at the edges as he took a step back. "As you can see, the new system greatly surpasses the previous one."

Bael blinked a few times to clear his head as the images faded into his memories. "How long have you been working on this? I thought you always had to expand manually using your own power?"

"Around ten years, though my luck has really been paying off in spades since the Supreme Commander foolishly brought the seeds back inside of humanity's border's a few years ago. I've infected several humans inside of their London stronghold. Using the information in their minds, I've been able to make this new labyrinth all but impervious to such rudimentary weapons as nuclear bombs." Satan waved his finger in the air and a phantom image appeared in front of him, showing a small cube that was slowly expanding outwards.

"So it uses the energy of those who live inside of it to expand... indefinitely? Does it have any limits?"

Bael, usually a thickheaded idiot, had taken quite the interest in this new labyrinth. Something about it fascinated him, knowing it would be ideal for their species to survive and thrive in.

The First Emperor leaned back against the broken desk, ignoring the dilapidated ruins of this once mighty skyscraper. The two of them were inside of an office building, one that towered thirty stories over the small buildings nearby, yet was dwarfed by others in the area. Fifty years without humans maintaining it had caused it to start sagging. In another fifty, it would surely crumble into dust.

"No limits in particular. I'm still using my own energy to expand it for now, but once it reaches an appropriate size, I'm moving every demon on Earth to it all at once. This will allow it to rapidly expand."

"Every demon? What about the sleeper cells?"

"They won't be needed anymore." Satan smiled smugly as he itched a small tuft of hair growing on his chin. "Only you, Belial and I know about those. Once our people are out, humans can keep their planet. We'll take it over once our numbers have built up again."

Despite his brave words, Satan hesitated. "There is one thing though... that human. Jason Hiro. His abilities are troublesome. Long have I dwelt on how I might be able to cripple him,

and yet I have no solution in sight."

Bael stared silently at the First Emperor. Satan had always been tight-lipped regarding Jason's abilities, though why he did not know. Perhaps now he'd be willing to open up. "You know what his abilities are, then?"

"Yes. I had wondered before what might happen if I spoke up, but now I think it is time I brought my generals into the fold. You will be the first to know, followed by Belial and Diablo." Satan paused to gather his thoughts before continuing. "You came to me and warned me of the Shadow's plot against me. He has been a thorn in my side, taking out several key seeds over the years, but I think that now even he cannot stop them. I am worried, though."

"Worried? You?" Bael laughed quickly, though his voice held a tinge of nervousness. "He's just one demon. You have thousands of years of evolutionary time over him, plus countless battles. He could never hope to defeat you."

"You are correct. However, it's not his power that I fear, or the fear that he might overpower me, but the meaning behind his existence. He is not connected to-" Satan hesitated as he shot a sideways glance at Bael before continuing. "-to the dark gods that govern the evolution of demons. He is forging his own path, independent of ours. What if others were to do the same? Chaos and disorder. Humans can live with such things, but demons are orderly, obedient. Demons understand the rule of might makes right. At the least, this is one trait we share with the angels and gods."

"I get it." Bael shifted uncomfortably on his feet. "What does this have to do with Jason Hiro's powers though?"

"His powers are not like those of heroes I've fought before. It's as if he was created to be the antithesis of all that makes me powerful. Any power I have he can counter with a single word... the only reason he has yet to eradicate me is an alarming level of stupidity."

Bael released a breath he didn't know he was holding in. "So you're saying he's a threat, but he's also too stupid to be a real threat. Why not just kill him."

"Nothing would please me more. The problem is that even if I do kill him, he has clones. Thousands of them. All of them have the same powers as he does. This simply isn't a battle I can win with a single pronged strike." Satan pressed his hand to his chest as he turned to stare out a half-broken window at the silent streets below. "Wordsmithing. The ability to create anything one desires with a single word. The only restraint on his power is the simple fact that he cannot chain multiple words together."

Bael stared uneasily at the First Emperor. "Wordsmithing? I don't get it."

"It's simple, so simple it will make your head hurt, yet layered with complexity. If he says 'flame', or 'fire', he can shoot fire from his hands, conjure up a wall of flames, convert water into flame... anything can happen, so long as he frames a mental image in his mind of what he wants to do and it's related to that word."

Bael seemed unconvinced. "Flames aren't going to hurt you. I don't see the problem."

"No, imbecile, they won't. But they *will* hurt my minions, the lower demons. Ignore the flames for a moment... Jason can kill anything by simply saying 'kill', or 'die', or 'death'. Don't you see? He could end all of demonkind with one word."

The Fourth Emperor seemed stunned for a moment, but quickly recovered. "Maybe, but I find that hard to believe. Even if he's an idiot, there's no way that wouldn't occur to him. You'd be dead right now. I'd be dead. Belial would be dead. Why hasn't he killed us?"

"Well, for the top ten demons, I've already protected us against such simple death words. The downside of words like 'die' or 'death' is that he has to frame a mental image of those he wants to kill, so demons are protected by simple virtue of anonymity. But... that pales in comparison... to what else he could do." Satan quickly turned around and stared Bael in the eye. "He's a true godlike figure, you know. His powers truly have no limits at all. The limits I just spoke of are actually nonexistent for him. He just hasn't realized the limits aren't really there. Once he does, only the mercy of the Creator will protect any he deems an enemy. It would be in our best interests to appease and cower to him."

Bael instantly took a step back. "Appease him? Cower?! I can't believe you'd ever say such a-" He caught himself mid-sentence, as a glimpse of horror spread across Satan's face. The First Emperor was not joking.

"This is a matter of life and death, Bael. This is bigger than either of us, bigger than demonkind even. He's a threat to reality as we know it. The only thing holding back this human are his delicate sensibilities and the morals instilled in him by those of his own kind... and those are fading all the time. He killed someone outright in front of me several years ago, and he didn't shift his emotions at all. If he abandons all forms of morality, then our only salvation is the final emotion that all beings of great power eventually face."

Bael waited but Satan didn't elaborate. "Which is...?"

"Boredom." A strange smile spread across Satan's face as he giggled nervously. "Ha.... haha... that's right. We can only hope that he becomes so bored by the weakness and frailty of humans, or that he tires of helping them out because they will grow too powerful, that he simply ignores the war effort. That's it. I have no counter. If Jason ever realizes his true power, and he decides to weaponize it against us, we're doomed. Doomed... hahaha!"

Satan's entire body shook slightly as waves of giggling emanated from him bit by bit. The sight of the First Emperor tittering like a crazy man sent shivers down Bael's spine.

After several long seconds, the laughter stopped and he wiped at his eyes. "Actually, to be honest, we do have exactly one hope. Because of that fucking suit that he wears though, it probably will never happen, but I'm keeping my hopes in check."

"And what might that be?"

Bael asked, but Satan shook his head in response. "He can read minds, Bael. I have Hades for protection, but you do not. There are some things that even Belial and you cannot know. Let's just say, if my plan ever worked, all of our problems would be solved instantly. It would require Jason to make a mistake so severe that I would have an opening, and it may just happen someday. For now though, I must not let my mental defenses slip."

Bael merely grunted in response.

After a minute, the two of them shifted on their feet and Bael worked up another question in his mind. "Speaking of which, how is Hades doing these days? Surely by now he's adjusted to his life as your backup."

"He fought me at first, but we've grown used to each other over the years. Actually, I'd say we're on... friendly terms now." Satan shrugged slightly. "That's up for debate though."

"Hunf." Bael glanced up at a clock on the wall. "It's about time I return to my duties."

"Yes, I agree. We'll talk again when the time is right. Make sure that shadow isn't up to anything too devious now."

"Can do." Bael lumbered over to the window and hopped out, falling dozens of stories to the ground below as he left Satan to his thoughts.

* * *

"To the future! Three years stuck in a black void on our way to making history!" The people around the table cheered and whooped as they slammed their glasses together, leaving even Jorge to smile widely as he bopped his glass mug into those of his crew.

A quick chug later, he downed a quarter of his glass before coughing violently, even as the others at the table laughed at him. "You've gotta get better at boozing it up, captain! You're embarrassing us!" One of the men jabbed him playfully in the ribcage with an elbow as he winked knowingly.

"Sorry guys, I'm still tryin'a be a bit more.... friendly." Jorge chuckled a little bit, as he felt the tips of his ears heating up. He didn't usually get this sloshed, but it was his Navigator's birthday today. Toby was the sort of man who worked without breaks and he deserved to have a

good time. It was good to let loose once in a while. "What ya say we play a game'o pool, eh fellas?" He could hear his words mashing together, but he didn't quite have full control of his tongue so he just rolled with it.

"Sounds good, captain. You have to break though." A woman on the other side of the table spoke up. Madelyn, the ship's head doctor. She was a fairly plain looking woman and she dressed somewhat frumpishly, as some of the men had remarked, but she had a good bedside manner and a pleasant disposition.

"I'll do that then." Jorge pulled himself up by his bootstraps and walked a few feet from the drinkers to the pool table where he quickly set the balls up in a triangle formation. Grabbing his favorite cherry stick, he stumbled over to the far side and slapped the cue ball down, took aim, and shoved the stick forwards, missing the ball completely and scuffing the green felt in the process.

"Ha ha! Oy, captain! You've got the aim of a blind man trying to shoot the wings off a fly!" Hawkeye walked into the room, trying mightily to contain his laughter and failing. "How drunk are you right now?"

"T'unno, I had like maybe... a beer're two?" Jorge took aim again, successfully hitting the cue ball this time as it sailed forwards, curved to the right, and slam dunked into the corner pocket, missing the other balls entirely. "Ah, shit."

"He's had three pints already, and he's working on the fourth." Madelyn shot Jorge a look that made him shy away guiltily from her gaze. "Don't worry about it though, he's a sloppy drunk but he could be worse. He doesn't drink often."

"Mmm." Hawkeye walked over and stood close to Jorge as he lined up one final shot, this time firing the cue ball directly into the triangle before him, but with too little power. The cue ball hardly shifted the others and merely glanced off, rolling to the side. Jorge started to curse, but Hawkeye leaned forwards and patted him on the back. "I think you've had enough to drink."

Jorge stared at the formation of pool balls for a few moments. "Yeah, s'think you're right..." He took a step to the side and tripped over his pool stick, forgetting it was still in his hand. Falling forwards, he smashed his head violently against a table and was knocked out cold.

"Jesus!" Everyone at the table leaped to their feet and hustled over to him, though the Navigation officer was first to arrive. "The captain is such a klutz sometimes."

Hawkeye rubbed his forehead. "Don't worry about it. I'll take him to the infirmary. He needs some rest anyway." Hawkeye paused for a moment as he leaned down to wrap Jorge's arm over his back. "Is he usually like this?"

"He mentioned he was kinda depressed recently. He does seem to be opening up a bit though." Madelyn reached down and helped Hawkeye raise the captain up as they both quickly walked him towards the hallway. "Sorry, Toby. We'll be out of your hair now."

"No worries. I just hope the captain's doing okay." The Navigator smiled worriedly as he watched the other two hustle out of the room.

* * *

A few minutes later, Jorge opened his eyes and winced as the room's lights blasted him in the face. "Crap, feel like I ate a fuckin' anvil with my forehead. Everything hurts."

"That's to be expected. You don't have a concussion or anything, but you took quite the fall." Madelyn walked over and shined a flashlight in his eyes as Hawkeye watched from nearby. "I see a slight bit of bleeding in your eye, so I'll just run a Hypocorder over your head. That should take care of the internal wound." Saying this, she whipped out a medical device, scanned his head, pressed a few buttons, and in seconds the pain was gone.

Hawkeye stared at the device evenly. "Human technology is really something. I might even be out of a job someday if it keeps advancing."

"Huh? What do you mean by that?" Madelyn glanced at him questioningly, but he just shrugged.

"It's nothing. Thank you for taking care of the captain, doctor Frey." Hawkeye gave a small wave and left the room a moment later.

"Nice guy. I never knew the Supreme Commander was so personable until I met his clone." Madelyn spoke, almost to herself before turning back around to Jorge. "You're free to go captain. However, you should really make sure not to overdo it in the future."

"Yeah... you're right." Jorge scratched at the back of his neck, but didn't make a move to get up from the medical chair. "I didn't see you drinking anything."

"Hm? I don't drink. I also don't smoke, but that's only somewhat related. I like to have my wits about me, and I care about my health." Madelyn walked over and sat in a chair across from him. "I have to say though, I've been seeing you in here a lot lately. On the surface, you're doing great and getting along with everyone... but I think you're not being totally honest about your feelings."

Jorge smiled sheepishly. "Was it that obvious? Geez." He wrung his hands together for a moment before continuing. "I uh... I saw my daughter last week. We talked over the starship communication network."

"Right. You mean Hawkeye's dimensional transmitter?"

"Yeah. She looks good. She's 18 now... I haven't seen her or hugged her since she was 15. It's been three years already."

Madelyn nodded neutrally. "Time is unmerciful. Do you regret coming on this trip?"

"Well no... but also yes..." Jorge smiled again, but this time it had a painful aura of fakeness about it. "I haven't been around my family for a long time. I miss them... a lot. But I also know a lot of people here, so it's not like I totally regret it!" He quickly spoke up as if to assuage concerns she might have that he hadn't enjoyed his time at all.

"Captain, let's be clear here. I'm not a psychologist. I do things that make the physical body feel better. I'm not trained for dealing with the mental health of patients, Beverly would be better for that. I'm just not sure what you want from me here..."

"Oh, right. Yeah. Sorry, I just thought since you were a doctor, maybe uh..." He chuckled nervously as he forgot what he was going to say.

Madelyn smiled pleasantly at him. "Look, if you want to talk, I'm happy to do so. I know what it's like being separated from your loved ones. I left my husband behind on Earth to go on this journey. Many others have too, though some brought their families with them. Most people here have made sacrifices... some more than others." Despite her smile, a tinge of sadness could be heard in her voice.

Jorge had a sudden realization as he remembered some rumors he had heard recently. "Oh... that's right... your husband. I'm sorry- I didn't mean to bring that up."

"It's fine. He's gone now, and I'll just have to live with it. I'm over it, really." Madelyn rubbed her arm for a moment before quickly standing up. "In any case, feel free to drop by if you need to talk, captain. Nobody wants you to fail or feel lonely. We're all here for you."

"Thanks, Doctor Frey." Jorge stood up and smiled at her as she smiled back.

"Ah, just call me Madelyn. The formality feels so stiff."

"Same to you, then. Just call me Jorge."

"I'd like that." The two of them smiled and nodded at each other politely before Jorge left the room, heading back to his quarters for the night.

Part 361a: Revenge

July 20th, 2120.

"I expected this to happen. You're on your own now."

Those words rang in Clarence's head as he ran on foot through the trees, keeping his head down low as he made his way forwards.

I can't believe she'd do this to me!

He was on the verge of having a panic attack, the only thing keeping his mind sane being that he had an angelic body that made him mentally stronger than one might expect. Somehow, large amounts of copious energy had allowed him to think more clearly than he would have as a human.

Unfortunately, that wasn't enough to save him now.

Sounds from all sides seemed to be closing in as he ducked down, cursing his luck that his body had to glow at this time of night. It was like a beacon directing his assassins towards him.

"Come out, Clarence! Hiding in the bushes only makes your weakness that much more apparent!" A voice boomed throughout the damp forest, making his lower lip tremble. The rain was dropping down slowly, only a trickle now. Only half an hour ago, its loudness was giving him the ability to move more quickly, and the fog had made him much less visible. But now...

"He's over here!" A voice sounded off alarmingly close and Clarence felt his heart jump into his throat as a glowing aura could be seen not even a hundred feet away through a few sets of bushes. If he could see them... they could see him.

He turned in the opposite direction of the voice and raced through the forest full speed, knowing this time they were right on his tail. *Should I take to the skies? No! They've got sentries above the forest, watching like hawks!*

He clutched his chest as he ran, taking stock of his energy reserves. *At the least, I won't let them escape unscathed. I have enough stockpiled... I'll make them regret cornering me like a dog!*

Missing a root sticking upwards, Clarence accidentally hooked his shoe under it, stumbling forwards clumsily and toppling onto his face as he ran. The sound of his body hitting the ground was like the sound of a piano smashing into concrete in the din of the night. He gasped in pain audibly and felt his entire body spasm in fear as several approaching footsteps turned directly towards him.

A thought occurred, as he spotted a relatively straight stick lying next to himself. *It'll have to do.*

He quickly grabbed it and imbued it with magic, hardening it as best as he could. Turning around, he held it in front of him as if he were a Kendo master. He had never done anything like this, but it was worth a shot. The alternative was suicide.

He didn't have to wait long, ten cherubim burst into the clearing and spotted him holding the stick. One of them raised his facemask. "Clarence, former preacher for the Church of Retribution. Lower the weapon and submit or we will strike you down where you stand." He placed his hand on his sword, but a smirk spread across his face. It was as if he were saying *try and hit me with your stick, I'll make you regret the thought.*

Clarence took a deep breath as he raised the stick up high. "The hell I will!" As he said this, he focused the magic on the tip of the stick, where every observer's eye was being drawn to. Without warning, a blast of light radiated outwards, blinding everyone except himself as it seared their eyes. Several cherubs screamed in pain as Clarence whaled on them with the stick, knocking five out cold in a matter of seconds.

Ignoring the rest, he did a partial levitation and flew away, moving noiselessly through the air as they howled in pain. Without a doubt, the bright light would attract those watching from above the forest cover and they would come to reinforce their fellow angels when they heard the multitude of screams.

In the dark it was hard to see what was ahead, and before he had a chance to react, Clarence flew straight into a rather thin tree that seemed to come out of nowhere. He let out a muffled yelp as his head smashed into it, causing him to tumble to the ground. When he glanced up and tried to shake the feeling off, several angels had already started to encircle him, one of which looked very familiar.

"It was a good try, false angel, but youth and inexperience will never escape age and cunning." An archangel with a long white beard stood several feet away, flanked by several cherubs and other guardian angels, all of them decked out in intimidating spiked white armor.

"Raphael! You bastard!" Clarence leaped to his feet and assumed his fighting pose as he aimed the stick at Raphael. "I won't let you take me alive!"

"Alive? Ha! That's an amusing joke, young one. You've got minutes left in your life as it stands, and that's if you're lucky." Raphael smiled politely, but an edge of rage could be seen under his veneer of melancholy. "I will however, grant you one last chance. Tell me who the female angel was... the one who you said was the mother of Jesus."

"Why the hell would I do that?" Clarence glanced around himself. The five remaining angels he had blinded just a minute before had joined in, and now he was totally surrounded. Escape would be impossible, and the same trick probably wasn't going to work twice.

"I want to know who she is. If you tell me, I will let you go... on the condition you never preach again."

"That's a death sentence. If I don't get at least a couple humans to pray to me, I'll die!"

"You'll die now if you don't tell me what I want to know." Raphael's voice chilled as he spoke, his tone leaving no room for misunderstanding.

Clarence lowered his eyes for a moment. Those years he had spent with Marie... the troubles they'd shared. She'd dropped him without a second thought. Once she heard the angels were looking for him, she had kicked him out into the cold without caring at all about the passion they had shared. Every night when she was being prayed to, she had begged him to enter inside of her, yet this was how she repaid him.

"Come now, young man. Just tell me who she is. It's easy!"

Raphael's words snapped Clarence out of his thoughts about the feeling of her lips on his, their hands joining together, her soft red hair that curled up at the tips. This was serious.

"I... if I tell you..." Clarence took a step forwards as he lowered the stick slightly. "You will... let me go?"

"Yes, yes! Of course, I am an archangel of my word!" Raphael jabbed his chest with his thumb proudly. "A wench who would kick you out should be worthy of no loyalty."

"You're right..." Clarence mumbled quietly to nobody in particular, as his eyes roved around. A small bug buzzed nearby, something resembling a dragonfly. It landed on his shoulder, and for the briefest of moments, he felt as if his eyes met its eyes and a bond was shared between them.

"...but I can't abandon the woman I love, even if she left me. To hell with you. To hell with ALL of you!"

Clarence reached inside of himself with nothing but his mental willpower, pulling forth an energy he didn't know he had. All around him, pebbles began to lift off the ground as gravity itself started to invert. A light shined inside of his chest, penetrating all the layers of his clothing as a high pitched wailing could be heard.

Raphael took two steps backwards. "Gods... is he going to... self destruct?!" He took another step as the energy began to condense into physical form, surging from Clarence's chest to his

right arm. His arm swelled up to three times its normal size, becoming freakishly huge as Raphael felt a strange terror take hold.

"Everyone, get away from him! He's-!"

"AHHHHH!" Clarence screamed in pain as he aimed his arm at the old man. A blast of energy shot forwards, created of all his reserves at once as he targeted the archangel in front of him.

This is for humanity, you demon.

The last thought Clarence would ever think slipped out of his mind as the energy itself screamed to life, devouring everything in its path. Raphael raised his hands to produce his own energy shield, but it was far too slow. A cacophony of laughter enveloped his body as millions of invisible minds ripped the flesh from his angelic form in delight. *REVENGE! BEAUTIFUL REVENGE!*

A few moments later, nothing was left. The beam continued tearing through the forest for several minutes before slowly dissipating, leaving only ash and death in its wake.

Clarence smiled as he fell to his knees. All the energy had left his body.

His form faded away to dust, as the strange dragonfly watched from nearby.

* * *

Marie stared at the screen in shock. The drone had followed him, as she expected, but this was unthinkable. Even she had not expected this scale of destruction, nor for him to use every last bit of his energy. She had assumed he'd leave a little bit to survive on, but clearly he was not very adept at gauging his energy use.

She folded her wings up behind her and stood up abruptly. "This changes everything."

Her human counterpart nodded as she popped a cookie in her mouth. "Mmm. I love these. So chewy."

"Stop stuffing your face. Focus. We just learned that spiritual energy is powerful enough to fight against the archangels."

She grimaced at the human Marie mashing food into her mouth, suddenly remembering she still clutched the killswitch in her hand. *Guess I don't need to use this now.* With a flick of the wrist, she tossed it onto a nearby table. *At least he saved me the trouble.*

After her counterpart swallowed her cookie, she smiled pleasantly and licked her lips. "How much energy did you give him, anyway? That was quite the blast."

"Not a lot, if I'm being honest." Angel Marie turned to stare at the screen now, feeling a strange emotion well up inside of her. "I figured that if he was going to be killed anyway, then it would be a waste to give him more than he needed."

"A waste, huh? Indeed." The other Marie kept silent for a few moments as she followed the angel's gaze to the screen. "You're going to run out of energy eventually, you know. He hasn't preached in a long time, and many of the faithful have become quite lax in their nightly worship. With Clarence gone, your ability to increase the faithful is basically zero now."

"I could probably mind control them. Maybe hypnosis would work."

"Funny."

"Yeah."

Both of them shrugged slightly. The angel sighed as she flicked a button to have the drone return home. "I genuinely need you to start praying to me every night. Every little bit helps. Just slap your hands together and will your energy to me, that's all you have to do."

"I'd sooner gouge out my own eyes." The human rapped her fingers on the desk for a moment. "You know, I have another idea. You don't necessarily have to ask people to pray to you willingly."

"Oh? What have you got in mind?"

"Humans respond to two things. Rewards and punishment. Promising them eternal life, even if you're lying, might just work... but punishment might too."

Angel Marie let the thought mull for a moment. "Are you saying I should whip people to get them to pray to me?"

"No, but keep in mind how the prayer system works. It doesn't seem to matter if the participants are willing or not... if they will their energy to you, that's that. Therefore, you could kidnap people, in theory, stuff them in cages, and force them to pray for you or you'll let them starve to death."

A strange crooked smile spread over the angel's face. "A Skinner Box. I see. This is... good. I need some angels to experiment on anyway, but capturing some humans as well for the sake of their energy would be a neat twist. Couple that with punishment and rewards later on, I can force them to give me their life force. It's... genius."

"Of course it's genius, love. We thought of it." The human cackled to herself as she slapped her knee. "Just think of it! You can create your own little cult to have the idiots pray to you in order to keep you alive! If they die, you just find more!"

"It's so deliciously evil that even I'm having doubts. I'll certainly go to hell for this!"

"Oh, come on. You can't go to hell... you're an angel!"

"You said it!"

Both Maries broke out in hysterical laughter as they eagerly started drawing up plans for their new idea.

Part 362a: Crisis Of Conscience

January 2nd, 2121.

Ohhh... fuck. Jorge sat on the edge of his bed, rocking back and forth slowly as the nausea came and went. *That's the last time I chug six beers in five minutes.*

The toilet whispered softly to him from across the room as the temptation to heave came and went with infrequent spurts. His eyes twitched as a strange sandy sensation sometimes shot up and down his back, causing him to yelp in pain but also try to keep his mouth closed so he wouldn't taste pizza and beer from the night before.

If there's a god out there, please let this horrible pain go away.

He glanced at the clock on the wall. It was 8 AM, and he hadn't slept at all. He'd only finished partying at the New Years celebrations around five or six, and the last two hours had merely added to his pain. As pointless as a holiday regarding an arbitrary 365 day year was in outer space, the crew aboard all three ships had been restless and suggested it. If there was one truth he had learned over his decades of experience in space, during the Energy Wars as well as now, it was that unless he was engaged in combat, space was dreadfully boring.

A gagging feeling suddenly exploded up his nose and Jorge decided his body would have to dictate his next actions. Rushing to the toilet, he blasted forth a solid half pound of bile from the deepest recesses of his stomach, the choking noise making him vomit some more after that. Meaty thick coagulated chunks of all the food he'd eaten on New Years Day was mixed in and the smell was like death.

Quickly, he flushed the toilet and gargled several mouthfuls of water before returning to the kitchen and filling himself a tall glass of ice water.

I hate myself sometimes.

Sitting down at his table, he was surprised as someone knocked softly on his door, not bothering to use the doorbell. Had he been asleep, he might have missed it, though that might be why they knocked so softly. It probably wasn't super urgent.

He sighed as he swallowed another gulp of ice water, then set it down and walked over to the door. Pressing the 'open' command on the door's keypad, it zipped open instantly to reveal a familiar face.

"Doctor Frey! Err, what bringsh you here..." His words slurred a little bit and he blinked his eyes heavily as he stifled a yawn.

"Commander, I saw you stumble out of the mess hall. Are you still drinking too much?" She stared at him expectantly, and he stared back blankly for a few moments. His brain couldn't seem to understand what she was saying, and finally he just nodded and grinned sheepishly.

"Uh... yeah." He continued to stare at her for several awkward moments before his drunken mind realized his lack of manners. "Oh right.. c'mon in, doc'." He beckoned into his quarters and she slipped in, bringing a small medical box along with her. "'W's in th' bag?"

She smiled politely at him and pulled out a couple of pills. "These are for you. Anti-nausea medication, and the blue one will help you with the hangover you're going to have soon."

"Pff, I ain't need any pillsh." Jorge refused verbally, but his hand automatically shot out to take them. "Ahh, did you hear me when y'were outside the room?"

"I'm sure half the ship did, commander."

"Oh. Sorry." Jorge walked away from the door back to the table, feeling his feet dragging like he had an anvil tied to his waist. Arriving at the table, he grabbed his glass of water and downed the pills in one smooth motion like a professional.

Madelyn followed after him hesitantly, having never been in his personal quarters before. Glancing around, she spotted a picture beside his bed. "Oh! Is this your wife and daughter?"

"Yup." Jorge rocked back and forth as he waited for the pills to take effect and calm his roiling stomach. "Amy and Sharah. Love 'em t' death."

"I see." The kitchen was right around the corner from his bedroom, and Madelyn slowly lowered the picture back onto his desk, placing it face down. "Your daughter is very pretty. Wife too."

"Yeap. It'sh been a long three yearsh." Jorge licked at his lips as a strange taste of chalk entered his mouth. He yawned slow and hard as he blinked many times, unable to shake the feeling of creeping exhaustion from his mind.

Madelyn walked around the corner and sat down at the table just across from him, smiling coyly. "Feeling better, commander?"

"Not really. Tired 's hell t' be honest." He stared at the woman witting across from him, blinking as she seemed to turn from two to three and back to one person. His vision was suddenly really weird out of nowhere. "God, I don't feel s' good, doc. Thanks for th' pills... but I gotta take a nap. Mind chatting later?"

"Feeling tired? That's fine. I'll go ahead and leave, then." She leaned across the table and put her hand on his, making his stupor clear away slightly. "You can always talk to me if you want to, alright commander?"

"Uh... sure thing." Jorge blushed as he felt a weird sensation in his pants. Was the doctor always this pretty? "Lemme just... walk you to th' door."

"Oh, that won't be necessary, commander." She pulled her hand away slowly and smiled at him, though the way she said it seemed ambiguous until she clarified. "I can walk myself out. Have a nice night."

"Oh. Okay." Jorge stared at her blankly as she stood up from the table and slowly started to walk away, almost as if deliberately so.

Suddenly Jorge stood up from the table. "W-wait, doctor Frey. I... uh..."

"Hmm?" She turned back and smiled at him as he took a step forwards.

Uneasily, he leaned against the doorway, feeling a strange fatigue in the back of his mind. "Oh man... I don't feel so good..."

A moment later he fell forwards, unable to see clearly as the doctor rushed over to him. "Oh geez, you silly man. Here, let me help you into bed." She winked at him slyly, which felt like it should raise an alarm bell in the back of his mind... but he couldn't quite understand why that was. "A doctor can order you to take bed rest, you know."

"Yeah... sounds good." Jorge wrapped his arm over her shoulder as she helped walk him several feet to his bed. Sitting himself down, he blinked at her in surprise as she ran her hand across his leg.

"You seem like a lonely man. Bed rest isn't the only thing a doctor can prescribe."

All he could do was nod dumbly as he stared into her strangely beautiful eyes. Yeah, this was okay. This felt right, for some reason.

This couldn't be wrong. She was a doctor, after all.

* * *

Standing on a rooftop as the cold midday air rushed past, all I could do was gawk in surprise. "How can he be dead?"

Gabriel sighed as he pulled his eyes from mine. "It's not... it's hard to say. To call him a brother would be too weak a word. It doesn't explain the bond we shared adequately. The thought he could die to a pseudo-angel, of all beings, is unthinkable."

"No kidding. Wow." I wiped at my forehead and pulled my coat a little tighter as an icy chill shot down my back. "So let me get this straight... he was killed by a pseudo angel, specifically the one he murdered as a human being, that Clarence preacher guy?"

"Yes. We knew that Clarence had secretly been convincing many humans to pray to him, but we never thought he could have gained such a level of power."

I felt an urge to speak up about my own feelings on the power of pseudo-angels and my experience with one in particular, but I decided to keep my mouth shut about it. "So that's it, then? He's just dead? Gone forever?"

"In a manner of speaking. All six archangels have a backup system for ensuring our life is not totally snuffed out. Two archangels were killed by demons during the Great War in Heaven many centuries ago, and their manner of death prevented the backup plan from working. However, Michael and Raphael's backup plans did work." To my surprise, Gabriel held up his hand and pointed at two rings he wore on his fingers. "Their souls were sealed inside of special rings designed millions of years ago. Only archangels have access to these holy artifacts. They are almost entirely indestructible."

A strange smile spread over my face. "Ha... haha... I'm familiar with these rings, actually."

"You are?" Gabriel looked almost incredulous. "How so?"

"Well, as you know, I come from the future. Specifically, a future where the demons have taken over the galaxy and the angels are all dead. So..." My voice trailed off and he seemed to understand.

"Ah. So they already had died. That's... unnerving. Have you really changed the future?"

"Well, you were dead in the future I came from too, so, it's still up for debate." I smiled at him awkwardly, but he didn't return the expression.

There was a slight awkward silence before he spoke again. "Michael, Raphael, Uriel, Hades... all of my brothers are gone. They were my closest allies, my confidantes. I'm the last archangel left. In the end, our power is still fading. We're still dying out slowly. We-"

I suddenly interrupted him. "Hold on, did you say Hades?"

"Yes. The Archangel of Death. He was the one who had spoken in secret with Michael to create a system that would make angelkind invincible against the demonic hordes. Hades passed away during the Great War in Heaven and never saw his work bear fruit. We weren't even able to recover his body, in the end."

"Oh." My mouth opened and closed as words formed in my mind, but I couldn't speak them.

Hades. I've heard the name. It took me a few minutes to remember where, but now the painful memories have come screaming back. He was the one inside of Satan's mind... a dark and powerful entity who cursed me for many years, reading my mind and stealing my memories.

And... he was an archangel? How did Satan take possession of him? How does Satan do any of the things I've seen him do?

Gabriel interrupted my thoughts. "You look like you've seen a ghost. Do you know something about Hades?"

"Um... sort of. I've heard of him in passing."

"Ah, that's understandable. He was a mighty archangel, but he was always a solitary figure. Humans might call him antisocial, but we would have the occasional talks here and there. He never came to the group meetings, and he tended to stick by himself. In retrospect, I wish I had spoken more with him before the demons slayed him. Then again... there are many I wish I could speak with now. So many gone." Gabriel smiled, but his eyes were hollow. I couldn't even see pain, simply emptiness. He had lost so many friends, death had become a way of life for him.

"You know, Gabriel... humans used to have a unique punishment called the death penalty, reserved only for the most heinous offenders."

He nodded slowly. "I am aware."

"Did you know they abolished the concept in the 2020's? Small tribes worldwide continued to do it, but eventually by 2050, international efforts managed to put an end to all such barbarism. The biggest reason for the shift was due to the coming nanotechnology boom and lifespan increasing far beyond the limits of 100 years. Do you know why?"

He shook his head slowly. "I do not."

"Human philosophers believed that a human sentenced to die who might have lived another 40 years would be a tragedy, but a nano-technology enhanced human might live forever. Surely, with decades of rehabilitation, even the worst offender could re-enter society to live normally. Killing them would be unthinkable. The value for an immortal being's life far outweighed the possibilities for a mortal one. Finally, even if they couldn't normally be rehabilitated, many scientists also believed that eventually we could map the human brain and come up with a way to disable psychopathic behavior. Therefore, all humans would one day be able to live in harmony, without violence."

Gabriel smiled finally, a sad, lingering thing. "How amusing. Humans being nonviolent? The sentiment is lost on me. There is nothing that I fear more than humans. Humans have the capacity to inflict pain like no other. Not even just in theory, but in practice. Further, all of societies limitations on such evil behavior are only ever a tentative hold on the average human's mental defenses. Every time the power goes out or humans need to survive by their own wits,

they always return to their violent roots. I've seen it countless times over just the last few hundred years."

Gabriel tilted his head up to look at the chilled clouds floating overhead. "Demons are evil, Angels are deceptive, the Volgrim are alien to the concept of emotions... but humans are the worst of them all. I mean no disrespect to you personally, but even you must know of that which I refer to."

I probably would have felt miffed, but instead I just shrugged. "Yeah, I do. Even I'm barbaric, in some ways. I've killed so many... my hands will never be able to wipe the blood away. Humans really are irredeemable, aren't we?" I chuckled slightly, and Gabriel joined in as he put a hand on my shoulder.

"You're not so bad. Don't beat yourself up, son. Thanks for listening to my problems. It... helped. A lot."

I smiled widely at him as I rested my hand on his. "Any time, Gabriel. Give my condolences to Zeus and all of the other angels."

He started to pull away, and as he did a question entered my mind. "Actually, ah, regarding the rings... see, I was able to communicate with you, Raphael, and Michael in the future I came from. Can you... can you speak with him?"

Gabriel didn't hesitate. "No. The trauma of death means that reforming will take him a very long time for his soul to regain all of his memories and knowledge. I cannot speak with Michael either. Someday, if I should live long enough, I will. But then... if I should die, I hope you will recover all of our rings, Jason. I am the most powerful of the archangels. If I were to die, that would mean a terrible calamity had occurred. So, please... make sure you recover our rings if that should happen."

"Yeah. I'll do that." I waved at Gabriel as he took a step back and mumbled some chants under his breath. "See you later, Gabriel."

"You as well."

He vanished in a flash of light, and a moment later only my thoughts remained with me on that chilly rooftop.

* * *

Sarah sighed happily as the car drove itself down the road. Autopilot mode was just so much better. A remix of a 21st century song, released in the 80's, played away. The bass drops and elegant electronic noises of synthetic dubstep really helped keep her in a calm frame of mind.

Her mom seemed to enjoy it too, which was always a plus. Most teenage girls were into that new third wave jazz, but Sarah considered herself a refined woman, able to appreciate the classics.

"What are you reading today, mom?" She lowered her head to try and get a better look at the cover, but her mom's hand was covering up the title.

"A biography about the life of Stephen Johannesburg, the last American President. He died fighting the Volgrim invaders head on, apparently, before they vaporized him with a bomb. Killed off a huge number of diplomats from around the world too. I never knew this stuff growing up." Her mom flipped the page and Sarah wondered to herself why she liked reading those paperbacks when there were so many more interesting and useful features with a datapad reader.

"America, huh? The demons run the north and south continents now. I wonder if we'll ever be able to retake them."

"I can't imagine we won't. The Supreme Commander is nothing if not reliable. Handsome too." Her mom giggled to herself at some naughty thought and Sarah smacked her arm.

"Mom! That's so gross!"

"Oh come on, a married woman can dream. Besides, I'm over a hundred years old now. Waiting a couple more years for your father to finish his mission is no trouble at all." Amy flipped to the next page as their hover-car rounded a corner, heading down the London streets towards the church again.

"You keep saying that, but it worries me." Sarah glanced down at her datapad as a new message popped up. *Check your notes when you get here, we've got a few last minute additions to your sermon today.*

She groaned audibly. "Yay. More work. Why can't the mid-week Thursday sermons be just a tad shorter? They always have to cram so much stuff in."

"Problems?" Her mom glanced away from the book for a moment as she sneaked a look at Sarah's datapad. "Oh. You poor thing, being all responsible and dependable and stuff."

"Oh, stuff it, mom. I only do this because nobody else will. Plus, there is this guy..."

Amy immediately rolled her eyes. "You're way too young to go looking for a boyfriend. Wait until you're eighty, like I did."

"I can't tell if you're joking!" Sarah and Amy both burst out into hysterical laughter. "You're lucky you found a man at all! Dad might have thought you were a crazy cat lady, being single at eighty!"

"Well, to be fair sweetheart, I looked thirty. Most women do. Nanobots are the *ultimate* makeup."

"Yeah... nanobots." Sarah's eyes shifted as she looked away from her mom. "Actually, I've been meaning to talk to you about nanobots. I um... given the history of the church and their belief system... I don't think I should use them."

Amy slowly set her book down, closing it up in her lap before turning to her daughter. "What do you mean?"

"Well, I'm not dumb, mom. I know that nanobots aren't the devil's nectar or anything silly like that, but everyone in the church has their eyes on me now. Being an impure human would make them all look at me differently if they knew I had been injected."

"How would accepting nanobots make you impure? That's one of the more radical beliefs the church has that I don't agree with. Maybe you should be using your status as the new minister to try and shift the church away from belief values like that."

"I'm *trying*, mom. I'm doing the best I can here. We've already succeeded in renaming the church and retaining membership from most people. We had a few people who thought the Church of Divinity was a terrible name, but I managed to convince them with Raphael's help that it was a necessary move. If we change too much all at once, people will start leaving in droves, spreading discontent everywhere."

Amy nodded silently for a few moments. "You know, when I was a young girl, the Pope of the Catholic Church came out as gay in the 2030's. It was crazy. People swore up and down that the end of days were coming, and the Volgrim were just demons set upon us by god as judgement for our sins. But, over time, people converted away from those extremist beliefs. Now being gay is accepted everywhere. Maybe you should try the same thing for the anti-nano injectors. It'd make a positive impact and reverse some of the damage Clarence has done."

"Ehh, maybe. I don't know." Sarah scratched the back of her neck slowly. "I mean, this isn't really the same thing. The nano-cancer is real. People are injecting things into their bodies that could be used by the government to spy on them or track their movements, not to mention many people die slow horrible deaths because of the nano-cancer."

"I totally disagree." Sarah braced herself as her mother went full argument-mode. "In the 1800's, humans died by the millions to smallpox, polio, anything you can think of. By the end of the 20th century, those diseases were eradicated, leaving only things like heart disease and lung cancer. While they claimed millions of lives per year, it was nothing compared to the deaths caused by the viruses and pathogens of the previous era. Compare that to now... humans only are infected by the nano-cancer, and that's it."

Amy paused as she thought of something else. "Hell, it's even better than that. Less than one percent of all people die to the nano-cancer, but of the 99% who don't, they will probably live *forever*. If we didn't have nanobots, we'd not only still be dying to heart disease and such again, we wouldn't live forever. We would go from a 99% immortality rate to a 0% immortality rate. It's incomparable."

Sarah spent half a minute silently trying to think of a rebuttal, but nothing came to mind. "Yeah... you're right. I can never outsmart you."

"Of course you can, but today is not that day." Amy smiled smugly as she lifted her book back up. "Just make sure Sister Margaret hears the abridged version of what I just told you before you go advocating for a total overhaul of the church's position on nanobots."

"Sure thing, mom."

* * *

Amelia didn't seem fazed by the news. "I don't really care if some ancient archangel was killed." I pulled up my coat as we stepped outside of the hospital into the bitter cold air. She, however, didn't even flinch. Wearing that same yellow sundress that exposed her to the elements, she didn't seem to feel the cold at all. Her body was really made of something else.

"I know you don't care since you don't even like the angels, but, like, you know... this is kind of big news. He was a goddamn archangel. Clarence killed him. Doesn't that blow your mind?"

"Yeah, I suppose. But in theory, if angels gain power by having people pray to them, then do the class distinctions of angel and pseudo-angel even matter? All you have to do is have people pray to you, and you can easily become stronger than an archangel. The only reason this doesn't happen more often is that humans are ignorant of the system, and the pseudo-angels are prevented from leaving Heaven." Amelia was completely disinterested in the conversation by this point, but a sudden spark appeared in her head. "Say, what if Hitler died and became an angel? If he could figure out how, he could have had millions of people pray to him!"

"That's not funny." I resisted the urge the glare at her. "Kind of a vile thought, if you ask me."

"I wasn't joking. Think about it, if someone with evil intentions could become an angel and convince millions, even billions of people to pray to them, their power could become quite enormous. Even a wordsmith might have trouble dealing with a threat like that."

Her words sounded almost ominous to me. "I've thought of how I could kill or neutralize the angels if they pulled something like that. I think just draining them of their energy would work, though it's tough to say. Hopefully I'll never have to try that out."

She and I walked for a few minutes before arriving at a traffic crossing. Amelia's body language felt tighter than usual, as if she had something going on. I felt the urge to inquire. "Anything happen recently?"

"Well, actually..." She glanced up into my eyes, and for a brief moment I thought I saw an emotion rarely shown by her... *fear*. "Ah, remember a few years ago, when all the people in the hospital I worked at were... slaughtered?"

"Yeah. What about it?" I responded casually, but she suddenly pulled close and looped her arm through mine.

"The demon. The one who did the killing. He came to me earlier today. I had those emergency new years patients to attend to, the lights went out... and he was there."

I suddenly felt alarm in the back of my mind. She seemed visibly uncomfortable. "What did he say?"

"He thanked me. He thanked me for allowing him to survive and freeing him from his captor. He... he was strong. Really strong." She hesitated, glancing behind us as if to check and see if anyone was watching. "He's been following me, Jason. I never even sensed him, and he has enormous energy. He must be able to mask his power."

"Is that even possible? Masking energy levels?"

"Of course. I do it all the time, but it takes never-ending concentration. The only way I can do it is if Levvy takes up the slack. Usually he's repressing my energy so that others can't notice, but occasionally someone does. The thing is... even when I looked directly at the demon, I couldn't sense anything. Neither could Levvy. Further, he was able to perceive Levvy inside of me. It was..."

Amelia paused and looked around us, as if an alarm had gone off that I couldn't hear. "Do you hear that? A buzzing sound."

"What? No." I turned to my left and felt my heart stop as a massive delivery van came barreling at me full speed. No time to react. I'm not wearing my hypersuit.

I quickly raised my hand to protect myself futilely, but Amelia was faster. She took two instant steps and jumped in front of me, digging her feet into the ground as the five ton vehicle smashed into her and came to an instant stop. Seconds later, several more vehicles raced at us straight on, as if they were aiming for us.

"Jesus Chris-" I cut myself off and aimed my mind at the ground. " **WALL!** " Instantly, a massive wall of metal shot up from the ground ten feet into the air, surrounding me on all sides as a sickening smashing of metal on metal blasted out all around me. Within ten seconds, the

sounds of crashing came to an end and I could hear screams all around. Amelia stood next to me inside the barrier, breathing evenly as if nothing had even happened.

"What the hell was that?! Put your hypersuit on and lower this barrier."

She spoke normally but her voice had an edge to it. I quickly wordsmithed my suit on and lowered the barrier, taking a step back in shock as fifteen vehicles sat in crumpled heaps nearby. Was this an assassination attempt?!

Amelia wasted no time, jumping to the delivery van and ripping the door off before taking a step back. "This driver is dead. Look for survivors, Jason. Keep an eye out."

I nodded quickly, sending a telepathic signal to the JIB right as several clones materialized next to me in full hypersuit attire. Seems they were keeping an eye on me as usual. Good.

"That took twenty seconds too long. I nearly died. Do better next time! Now help me look for survivors!" I barked orders at them and they nodded quickly, not bothering to retort.

A minute later, we'd pulled several corpses from cars, and more than a few people were intact. I glanced down at a young girl, shivering at how badly her face was mutilated. " **Heal!** "

A couple seconds later, her face was healed and I found myself staring at her lifeless body. She looked... familiar.

"Jason! Over here!" Sensei walked up to me, holding a woman's body in his arms. "I've got another one, but she's in bad condition." He set her down and it took all of two seconds for me to remember her.

Amy Gutierrez. She was the woman who found planet Revival. *Shit*. She had a husband too, Jorge if I remember. He's on his way to that planet now.

" **Heal.** " I quickly healed up her body, waiting several moments in suspense before she coughed violently and sputtered back to life.

She blinked slowly, staring up at me for a moment as she suddenly remembered what had happened. "S-Sarah... where's Sarah?" Her eyes lolled around in her head as the healing took a few more seconds to complete. The instant she had some strength back, she sat up and noticed the girl in my arms. "Oh god! Sarah! SARAH?!"

I quickly noticed the family resemblance. They looked just like each other. Shit... at least I managed to heal her face.

"Ma'am. I'm sorry... your daughter is... she didn't make it."

Amy didn't even cry tears, her hands just shook in fright as she gently touched her daughter's face. The shock of what happened must have broken her mind temporarily. "She...

she can't be dead. Look, she's in perfect condition. Sarah... Sarah wake up... it's mom. Come on, baby. Wake up, sweetheart." She brushed aside her daughter's hair as I held the girl in my arms, and for a moment, the scene felt all too familiar to me. Holding the body of a dead girl in my arms...

For the first time in a hundred years, I felt tears crawl down my face, in place of this woman's pain. "Amy... she's not going to wake up. She's- she's gone now. She's gone."

Against my better judgement, I lifted my helmet off, ignoring the danger of a potential assassin in the area. I put my hand on her arm. "She's gone."

"No... god no. I told her to autopilot the car. This is my fault. I can't believe it, I can't... I can't..." Amy reached over and pulled her daughter out of my arms. For some reason, I didn't want to let go, but I did. I gingerly handed the young woman over to her mother and stood up, wiping my tears away as I walked a few paces from the two of them to give them some privacy.

Amelia walked up to me and immediately was taken aback by my tears. "Jason, are you okay? What's wrong?"

No matter how I wiped, I couldn't stop the tears. "Ah, it's n-nothing. Just give me a minute."

Reflexively, I knelt down and wrapped my arms around Amelia, hugging her with crushing force as I felt my chest heave. Why am I crying so hard? I didn't even know this girl. I didn't know her at all.

Despite my forceful grip, it was probably nothing to Amelia, and she hugged me back. We stayed like that for several seconds before I pulled away and shook my head. "God, I'm sorry. I'm a mess. I don't even know why I'm crying. Fuck."

"There's nothing to be afraid of, Jason. I protected you from the cars. I know you might have been scared but-"

I raised my hand to silence her. "No, that's not it. Thank you, Amelia. That just... isn't it though."

Fuck.

I turned back to stare at the grieving mother.

I can't believe things like this still happen. Senseless acts of violence.

* * *

Marie smashed her glowing fist on the desk. "SON OF A BITCH! Who the fuck is that little cunt?! She stopped the van with her bare hands!"

The viewscreens before her showed complete chaos. More than a dozen hover-vehicles had smashed into traffic lights and each other at an intersection, yet Jason Hiro had once again evaded death, the little shit.

"She wasn't in the plan. Is she a demon? She looks totally human. But hey, we accomplished one sub-objective." Marie's human counterpart sat beside her at the desk, blowing bubbles with her bubblegum. A new habit she'd picked up recently, the popping sound was a subtle infuriating noise that grated on the angel's nerves.

"Yeah, I got my revenge. This little bitch got Clarence killed. I was fond of that puppet, and I had to let him go. At least I have this hollow victory." The angel threw her hands up in the air as she jumped up from the desk, her nostrils flared as her temper raged. "Fuck! I want that woman's name! I want to know everything about her! She is no normal homo-sapiens, I'll tell you that much."

Another *crack* blared in the small room as the human blew her stupid bubbles. "I may have seen her once or twice, but I don't know anything about her. I'll keep an eye on her from now on and see what I can dig up."

"Yeah. Do that." The angel seethed for a few more moments before taking a long deep breath to cool off. "Ah, it's not all bad I guess."

"Of course it isn't. Always look on the bright side of life!" Human Marie flicked the monitors over to a nearby hospital. "Satan's going to send some goons out tonight. We'll have the first batch of test subjects before you know it."

"Great. Fantastic. Just another thing to scratch off my bucket list."

"Don't be like that. I'm doing this for you anyway." The human pulled the gum from her mouth and tossed it in a trashcan next to the desk. "Things could be a lot worse, you know. We could both be dead, for one."

"Don't even joke like that."

"It's only a joke if it's funny."

* * *

Jorge blinked slowly as the room came into focus. Everything hurt in ways he hadn't experienced before, and he felt like his head had been repeatedly smashed against an anvil.

That was when he realized someone was pounding at the door and ringing his doorbell furiously.

"Jorge! Jorge, open up!" A deep male voice yelled and sounded extremely frustrated and agitated. Jorge started to get up before realizing his arm was pinned in place. Glancing to the

side, his heart skipped a beat as he realized there was someone in the bed with him. A female. A naked woman.

The doctor.

He stared at her for three seconds as his mind raced. *What the hell is she doing here? What did I do last night?*

Then the memories came rushing back. The alcohol, her late night visit, their passionate embrace. The temporary feeling of loneliness having vanished, if just for a few hours.

The crushing realization of the horrible mistake he'd made.

"Oh god." He barely breathed the words before he heard a clicking sound as the door opened.

Hawkeye walked in, his face pale and a horrified expression on his face. "Jesus Christ, if you were awake you should have opened the door! There was an accident, and your-"

He froze as he glanced from Jorge to the woman in bed beside him.

"Who... who is that?"

Jorge stared blankly at Hawkeye, unsure of what to say. "Uh... this isn't what it looks like. I was drunk last night, some things happened... I fucked up."

"Yeah. Yeah you did." Hawkeye's mouth opened and closed as he licked his lips. "I ought to beat the shit out of you, but there's no point. Your wife and daughter were just in an accident."

Jorge's eyes shot open as the words washed over him like ice water down his back. "Wh-what?! An accident? What do you mean?"

Doctor Frey stirred, their loud voices shaking her from a deep slumber. A second later, she sat up in bed and pulled the covers over herself, breathing hard as soon as she saw Hawkeye.

"Uh. H-hi."

"Shut the fuck up." Hawkeye didn't even look at her. "I have words for you later. Jorge, your wife is alright. But your daughter... she... she didn't..."

Jorge felt horror overwhelm himself as his hands raised up to his face, as if to shield his eyes. "She's still alive... right? Is she in the hospital?"

"No. Your daughter... she died. I'm sorry." Hawkeye's sadness was gone now, and he almost seemed to be enjoying delivering this news. It was as if he was punishing an unfaithful man for his infidelity.

"No... she can't be dead... oh fuck. Oh... fuck." Jorge felt tears bubbling up unbidden, even as Doctor Frey climbed out of bed and tossed her clothes back on, oblivious to Hawkeye's gaze.

"Where are you going?" Jorge stared at her as she started to walk out of the room.

"I'm out. This is too deep for me. Not worth it." With a voice of steel, she walked out of the room ignoring the pleading look in his eyes.

Hawkeye didn't even look at her as she left. "I can't believe you. Of all the times..." He bit his lip and looked away, out the window towards the stars passing by. "I'm not going to beat you up over this, even if I think you deserve it. This is... punishment enough. Your wife is on the comm line. When you get your act together, go talk with her. We'll keep this between ourselves."

He didn't wait for a response before storming out of the room.

Jorge finally let the tears stream down his face.

"FUCK! SHIT! I deserved this! I deserved this!" He punched himself in the head violently as he sat in bed, sobbing for several minutes before picking himself up and putting on his clothes.

I deserved this, but Amy didn't. I can't let her grieve alone.

A minute later, he left the room and headed out to go talk to his wife.

Part 363a: Framed

The viewscreen came to life and froze for several minutes on a pure white image as the signal waited for the receiving end to connect. Jorge rubbed his hands together nervously and wiped at his face every now and again. The clock on the wall ticked down and it took all his control not to burst into tears.

Get it together, man.

He goaded himself angrily as he thought about what he'd done. *I cheated. Jesus Christ. I can't believe myself.*

Amy would never cheat on him. She'd prodded him and winked and giggled about the Supreme Commander, but he knew deep down she'd never do such a thing. Then when he did the worst thing a man could do to his beloved wife, the gods themselves reached out and punished him.

And I deserved it too. But... Sarah didn't deserve it. Shit!

God was a cruel bastard. No... Jorge felt it, deep in his heart. There was no god. They were all fakes... false persuaders. God had nothing to do with this.

His wife and daughter had been on the way to church though. *Maybe I'm wrong. Maybe this really was a punishment for my infidelity. How can I face her after this?*

The screen shifted from pure white to an empty room, making Jorge stiffen as his eyes shot to the center of the screen. A set of chairs and a couch were beside each other, but nobody was there. An eerie silence filled the room on the other side of the broadcast, and Jorge felt himself lean forwards slightly, as if trying to peek around a corner that wasn't there.

Another minute passed, and finally an older man shuffled onscreen, his hospital lab-coat and thick rimmed glasses indicating he was some sort of surgeon. His nameplate said something, but Jorge couldn't quite make it out.

"Oh, erm, you're the husband of Amy Gutierrez, correct?" He looked at an old fashioned clipboard in his hand and lightly lifted a page an inch or so. "Jorge L. Gutierrez?"

"Y-yes. That's correct."

The man nodded slowly as he lowered the clipboard slightly. "I do regret to inform you of this, Mister Gutierrez, but your wife will not be able to speak to you in her present condition."

Jorge felt his heart in his throat as he waited for the doctor to elaborate, but he simply stopped there, as if that was all he needed to say. "Her present condition? What do you mean?"

Is she doing badly?"

"Hard to say, honestly." The doctor forced a weak smile, but then stopped, as if remembering he shouldn't even hint at a positive emotion during a trying time like this. "Her body is in perfect condition. The condition of the vehicle she was in and the results from the rapid response crash investigator indicated she must have slammed her head into the dashboard, causing a severe skull fracture... but her body is in absolutely pristine condition. She simply will not wake up." He shook his head slowly. "I don't get it. In all my years, I've never seen a case so perplexing. One for the medical books, that one is."

"I'm right here, you know." Jorge stopped himself from glaring madly at the doctor onscreen. He seemed almost senile, or perhaps he was just a sociopath who didn't understand normal emotions. Working with people who died constantly could ravage one's sanity over a long period of time, not that it was any comfort to Jorge in that moment.

"Yes, yes. My apologies." The doctor scratched the back of his neck and bit his lip as he averted his eyes from the man before him. "In any case, it all depends on if she wakes up. You're free to visit her if you like, but the best I can do for you right now is show you a picture of her."

"I'm about a thousand lightyears from Earth, doctor. A visit is out of-" Jorge stopped himself, before mentally facepalming. *Hawkeye can probably get me home in the blink of an eye.* "Never mind, I'll see what I can do. And... ah, Sarah. My daughter. Did she... did she at least g-go quickly?" He choked slightly as tears formed in his eyes. *I can't break down right now. My wife would want me to be strong for her.*

"I assure you, Mister Gutierrez, her passing was instant. I doubt she felt a thing." The doctor shuffled on his feet but Jorge was staring at the ground as he wiped his eyes. He didn't even notice the doctor's gaze as a hand beckoned him offscreen. "Sorry to leave so abruptly, but duty calls. I have three other patients from the crash I must see to."

"Yeah. No problem, doc. Thanks." Jorge mumbled half-heartedly, and when he looked up, the doctor was already gone, the quiet sound of a door hissing shut barely audible in the background.

"Harsh." A voice spoke up suddenly and Jorge flinched in his seat, surprised to see Hawkeye silently entering the room. "I heard some of it. Your wife probably suffered mental damage that Jason was unable to heal properly. We can heal the body, but not the mind... or the soul."

"Fuck." Jorge let the word slip without thinking. "This is my fault."

"Not really, but you certainly aren't blameless." Hawkeye, ever the persistent one, didn't let up. "You picked a fine day to cheat. Luckily, unless Doctor Frey blabs about it, it should stay between the three of us."

"I'm sorry." Jorge sighed in defeat, but this only seemed to annoy the clone standing in the doorway.

"There's no reason to apologize to me. Rather, if your wife wakes up, you should apologize to her. Hell, it probably doesn't even matter anymore." Hawkeye seemed to spit the words out as he stared at the now blank viewscreen in frustration. "You can't bring back your daughter. She's gone, now. Keeping things between you and me might be for the better... Amy's already heartbroken enough."

Jorge stared silently at the ground for a few moments. "You said 'if' my wife wakes up. Do you think there's a chance... she won't?"

"I don't know. I'm not a doctor, not in the slightest. I've done far more research and practice with my abilities than even the Original has, yet I still know so little. If she's in a coma after being healed, she might not awaken for a few days, or weeks, or even months."

"Or years." Jorge finished the sentence as he leaned back in the couch and instead stared at the ceiling. "I'm a failure."

"Come on, that's not the attitude to keep." Hawkeye walked over and sat down next to Jorge, gently punching him in the arm. "Tell you what, this crew can go on without you. I'll send you home, and you spend every day by your wife's side until she wakes up. How does that sound?"

"That's... for the best." Jorge smiled at Hawkeye, but his returned expression was blank, maybe even stern.

"There's more."

"Come again?"

"I spoke with the doctor. Miss Frey." Hawkeye licked his lips slowly as he kept his eyes locked onto Jorge's. "She told me that you coerced her into your room, were acting very strange, and then you sexually assaulted her."

Jorge felt his mouth start to form words, but his mind was totally empty. "What?"

"You were drunk at the party. Everyone knows that. You also get rather mouthy when you've had a few too many. Problem is, I'm reading your mind, and I've read hers, and I can't tell if she's lying or not." Hawkeye grinned imperceptibly. "So what is it? Did you or did you not?"

"No... I wouldn't do that..." Jorge felt his gaze slip away as he looked at the ground. *Would I? I can't remember last night at all. I barely remember what we did once we were in bed. Would I do that?*

"I don't know if you did or not, but if the rumors get out on the ship, it'll be major problems for the both of us. Her story sounds credible enough, though I doubt her words. The last thing I

need is a ship wracked by scandal." Hawkeye stood up abruptly. "So yeah, it's for the best you are no longer a part of this mission. No hard feelings, I hope? You need to be with your wife anyway."

"Yeah. My wife. Need to be with her." Jorge parroted the words, but he didn't understand their meaning. He felt so numb he could barely even think.

"I'll send you back to Earth in the morning. Make sure you say goodbye to your crew. They deserve that much from you. The official story will just be that your wife was in an accident and you're leaving to see her, nothing else."

"Thanks. I appreciate it."

Hawkeye tapped his foot slowly. "God, I hope she's lying. I really do." He turned towards the door and opened it up but froze in the doorway. "If I find out she isn't, there will be hell to pay. I'm not soft like the Original."

Without another word, he walked through the doorway, leaving Jorge to his thoughts.

* * *

Deep underground, in a large space carved out by hand and magic over several years, where no light could ever hope to penetrate, two demonic entities of darkness mucked about in silence.

Relative silence, that is.

"So then I was like, 'Nooo don't attack Satan! Idiot, you'll die!' But then he was all like 'I am stronger now, you haven't seen my true power!' and he still got his ass whooped!"

Yama groaned as the being in the orb chattered at him nonstop. He always did this. "Can't you simply be silent for once in your existence?"

"Absolutely! All you have to do is give me back to Lady Belial! That's it, pal! Nothing to it!" The being inside the orb, 'Valac' as he called himself, was apparently a powerful demon lord from an age past, before even the Great War in Heaven that all demons spoke of in whispers. Despite this, he acted like an annoying loudmouth, and Yama had long since realized it was just an act so that he'd be annoyed enough to send the orb back to the Second Emperor.

"Your power is wasted on her. Females are inferior specimens compared to the male."

"Sounds like something an idiot would say! Females are so much nicer to look at, and so much kinder too! All you do is mope around all day, rasping about how you're going to kill all humans! You're just as boring as Satan, except all he does is blather about the angels! Two sides of the same coin!" The annoying falsetto Valac was deliberately putting in his voice seemed to have the desired effect of making Yama wish he had thought the capture out more carefully.

"It occurs to me that I should just stuff you in a box and only take you out for special situations."

Valac's cheerful demeanor seized up and he almost choked when he responded. "You wouldn't."

"I should find one of those energy nullifiers and stick it in the box with you. I think you'll find them quite relaxing."

"Fine. Geez." Valac sighed as his voice deepened slightly. "You're not much fun. Belial used to talk to me about her day... she always treated me nice."

"I am not Belial." Yama gnashed his teeth as the shadowy haze fell off his body. "You were right, though. The human female known as Amelia... I felt the presence inside of her. The dark one."

The demon in the orb groaned to himself silently. *Once again, this doofus is going on about that human girl.* "Why don't you just grab her and have your way with her already? After you do, let me go back to my own woman."

Yama seemed irritated by the suggestion. "Fool. I am beyond such worthless feelings."

"I doubt that. You clearly feel something towards her."

The Shadow didn't respond, as he merely seethed to himself wordlessly.

"Look, I was never much of a ladies man, understand? I sort of died in my prime on the field of battle. Still, you're worse than clueless, you're-"

Yama didn't let him finish. "I have had many trysts with dozens of females. All were before my evolution to a Shadow."

"Oh."

There was an awkward silence as Valac felt slightly irritated at the cocksure way Yama had just said that.

What a jackass. I hate the way he humble-brags about everything. Must be nice to get to walk around and teleport and be all powerful and cool and awesome. At least he's a loner and doesn't receive any appreciation.

Valac mumbled and grumbled silently to himself as Yama stood up and walked away from the orb, staring at a mechanical clock in the room that normally would be totally impossible to read, given the lack of light. "Night draws near. We'll be going up to the surface in an hour or so."

"Hooray. You really hate the light, don't you?"

"Yes. It's like a burning pain all over my body, as if I were being dipped in fire head-first. The brighter the light, the more excruciating the pain."

"Hmm." Valac tapped on his lip in Yama's mind's eye. "Sounds rather inconvenient. Without a doubt, you are a very strong demon, and you definitely bested Belial, but that's a pretty troublesome weakness. Satan has no such weaknesses."

"Incorrect. Satan has at least one major weakness. I've already prodded him with it once, though I will admit his weakness is less acute than my own. Certainly harder to take advantage of."

"Oh yeah?" Valac perked up slightly, as he felt rather interested in this piece of news. "And what's that?"

"The female he loves, of course. Belial. Lilia, as he calls her in secret."

Valac felt his jaw slacken slightly. "Uh... do you mean like, taking her as a hostage or something? I don't see that accomplishing anything. He certainly cares for her, but- hey wait a minute! How do you know his secret name for her?"

Yama sighed as he picked up the orb and stared into it in the darkness of the room. "Everywhere there is darkness, I can see if I so choose. Naturally I keep an eye on him at all times, so I am privy to much private information."

"Great. A stalker's wet dream." Valac, ever the crude one, stuck his tongue out at the shadow. "You're a real creep, Yama."

"Thank you."

"It wasn't a compliment."

Part 364a:

January 3rd, 2121.

The streets of London were always quiet in the dead hours of the night. They were the perfect time for a man to go walking around aimlessly, so long as he wasn't worried about muggers. The crisp winter air and light snowfall meant the streets were illuminated more than usual by the light of the moon, making it easier to get around.

This was especially relevant, considering it was the poor side of town. With few streetlights working in the area, the lightly armored figure walked slowly down the street, taking in the sights and wondering why so many lights were smashed and not working properly.

"Another one. What does that make, thirty? Thirty-one?"

The gruff voice spoke out, barely audible under normal circumstances, but totally silent now outside of the helmet he wore.

"TWENTY NINE LIGHTS, AS OF THIS BLOCK."

A robotic voice spoke in his ear and he nodded slowly. "Knew I'd lose count."

The man wearing the hypersuit shifted uneasily. He'd been gathering data for over a year now, and this part of the city was always the one where the reports came from, and always in the middle of the night. There wasn't a pattern to the specific locations, but the general area always had something going on.

This far from HQ, the city feels like a maze. What moron designed this street layout?

"Centurion, have you detected any demonic activity yet?"

"NEGATIVE, PILOT JASON HIRO."

The man groaned. "That isn't my name. That's Original's name. Christ."

The AI was able to tell all of the clones apart, of course, but he almost seemed to take pleasure in calling them all by the same name, no matter how they wanted to be referred to. Pleasure was probably too strong a word, though, given he was a low level intelligence.

The clone lifted his head to look up at the light above him. " **Repair.** " A moment later, the old fashioned bulb on the inside as well as the glass cover that surrounded the underside of it healed themselves, and soon it was at least four times easier to see than before.

"Jason never pays attention to the little things. In this case, the devil is in the details."

Literally. He reached around to scratch an itch on his back, but stopped himself when he realized the suit was covering the spot up. *Oh well.*

As he stood under the light, staring at a map on his HUD, a chill went down his back as a scream and a loud *crack* sounded off a few blocks away. A gunshot, and made from one of those ancient weapons at that, the gunpowder type.

The scream was male, and it sounded full of fear, so it didn't seem to him like a simple mugging or a home intrusion. *This might be it.*

"Centurion, locate the source of that noise."

"AFFIRMATIVE. QUERY COMPLETE. LOCATION NOTED ON YOUR MAP."

The clone barely even gave it a once over before he dashed forwards, rushing towards the source of the ruckus. Mid-stride, he began teleporting forwards, using his limited site-to-site range teleporting, popping from the ground onto a rooftop, and from there across a couple more. In under fifteen seconds, he had already arrived at the scene of the crime.

A red dot appeared on his map, showing him the location was inside a small four-story apartment building. The appearance was dingy, brown. The red bricks had faded from their once vibrant color from decades, possibly a century or more of atrophy and water damage, and garbage was piled in bags in the alleyway. If he weren't wearing the helmet, he knew the stench would be unbearable.

Silently he teleported to the ground level, and surveyed the area with caution. All of the snow within a two block radius was gone. His suit reported the ambient temperature appeared to be ten degrees warmer than usual, which seemed impossible under normal circumstances.

These aren't normal though. This must be what I'm looking for.

He quickly walked up to the door, pulling an anti-energy rifle out of the air before him by wordsmithing it out of storage. Normally he wouldn't bother with such trivial toys, but he had to be cautious. At least one demon already knew how to nullify some effects of wordsmithing, and he wasn't about to assume Satan had kept that information to himself.

Unlike the Original.

He kept that thought to himself. Original was very busy. Running a planet was a lot of work for one as lazy and unmotivated as he was. It was probably better to leave the more serious matters in the hands of his clones anyway.

" **Detect.** "

He hissed the word under his breath, though it wasn't really necessary. The helmet completely nullified all noise from escaping, but he was a paranoid man.

What he sensed made him shiver slightly. There was no individual demonic presence that coalesced into a single individual demon. Instead, the presence seemed to be all over the place, in every nook and cranny of the building. The demon energy was all over the place, impossible to pinpoint.

Wonder who I'm dealing with. He directed the rhetorical mental thought at nothing in particular.

His acute hearing made him perk up as he heard a labored breathing on the second story. "Help me... help me... help me..." A man wheezed and barely whispered the words. It sounded as if they were his last words.

I'm not rushing into there. Could be a trap. The clone quickly wordsmithed again. " **Heal.** "

By aiming his mind at the man's position, he listened for a couple seconds as the man coughed in shock. He clearly had not expected to randomly start feeling perfectly fine. The thought of his confusion made the clone almost chortle to himself.

Almost, but not quite. There was still the matter of whatever had attacked him.

He was so focused on the man upstairs, he failed to notice the silent tendril of shadow that shot from the darkness, grabbing hold of his leg as he gave out a startled yelp. With an unthinkable force, it yanked him backwards and hurled him across the street into a totally different building, smashing him through two sets of walls and pinning him down as several more joined in wrapping around his arms and legs.

"What the hell?!" He hadn't even had a second to realize what happened, but thanks to the hypersuit he hardly even felt the impact of his landing. "Get the fuck off me!"

He quickly teleported straight up to the ceiling of the room, contorting his body in midair so he could teleport outside a millisecond later. Adrenaline rushed through his brain as he landed on the street and whipped his head around in worry. "Centurion! Source of the attack?!"

"SOURCE UNKNOWN. DEMONIC ENERGY PERMEATES ALL THROUGHOUT THIS SECTOR. BACKUP ADVISED."

"Yeah, no shit." He quickly sent a mental message to the JIB, and two clones materialized next to him a few seconds later.

"Idiots! Put on your hypersuits!" He scowled at them and they turned white in the face, as they coughed the words under their breath needed to make the suits appear.

"Sensei, what's going on?" The first clone to arrive spoke first.

"Something attacked me. Dunno what it is. Grabbed me out of nowhere and smashed me into that building. Be on the lookout." He spoke over the comm and they nodded their heads to

follow suit. Best to not let the attacker know what their plans were.

"Oh, how perfect. Three at once." A voice whispered throughout the entire area, causing the hair to stand up on the back of Sensei's neck. "As good a time as any to see if my research about the Supreme Commander is correct."

"Who are you?" Sensei spoke up and looked around everywhere, but no demon came out of hiding. "Show yourself."

"That would seem to be a bad idea. Your ability can prove to be quite... flexible." More tendrils of shadow leaped out from the darkness, one of which Sensei spotted as he quickly jumped up to avoid it and teleported several feet forwards. The other two weren't so lucky as they met the same fate he had less than a minute before. Their bodies went flying in different directions, careening into nearby buildings and causing quite a ruckus. By now, a few people had turned on the lights and were looking out their windows to try and figure out who was causing all that noise.

Just as Sensei had done before, the two clones broke free and teleported back to their original location, this time standing back-to-back as they looked around worriedly. "What was that?!" They both practically shouted in unison, making Sensei think to himself how despite their differences, clones could still have weird similarities.

"Something is attacking from the shadows. I can't pinpoint the assailant's position. Without a doubt though, he's a demon." Sensei replied, but he was unsure of the exact details. *The question is, what kind of demon exactly?*

"I've been meaning to test something out. Let me know how this feels." The voice that permeated the dark streets whispered again, and something about his tone made Sensei's skin crawl. "I don't like being interrupted when I'm doing my business. Consider this a repayment for my time that you've wasted."

The clones didn't get a second to wonder what he meant. From under their boots, a shadow formed in the pure darkness, passing through their suit's inner defenses, and arriving in the pitch blackness of their inner bodies. A moment later, the suit had just begun to register the new presence inside the suits, but it was already too late. The shadows exploded outwards in a trillion different directions, as if a bomb had detonated inside of their bodies.

Sensei stared ahead blankly as Centurion said... something. He wasn't sure of what. He didn't care either. He flopped to the ground like a ragdoll and closed his eyes slowly, feeling absolutely nothing.

"RED ALERT. PILOT JASON HIRO'S LIFE SIGNS HAVE CEASED. ACTIVATING EMERGENCY ESCAPE DEVICE NOW."

All three hypersuits instantly sent a signal to Harold, who quickly beamed them back into the Mothership, where the JIB received them a moment later.

On a rooftop in London, a demon encased in blackness seethed to himself. "Foolish. I should have realized they would have such countermeasures."

"You didn't think you'd just take him out and that would be it, did you? He's got the world's best scientists helping him out. I'm sure he has plenty of tricks up his sleeve." Valac snickered to himself at the massive flop the unexpected operation had resulted in.

"Yes, but wordsmithing is his most potent ability. Everything I've seen implied that he would rely on it far more than other defensive and offensive methods. I'll just have to be more careful next time."

"Yeah, you do that, pal." Valac rolled his eyes. "Just make sure when you die that Belial knows you're gone. I don't wanna end up in Jason's hands."

"I don't plan to die, imbecile. Keep your stupidity to yourself."

"Yeah? You didn't plan to have all three of his clones teleport away either, did you? Seems some plans of yours just fall apart."

Yama flinched at the orb's words, but had no appropriate response.

"Whatever. Let's get going." Yama turned from the rooftop's edge, flicking his mind down to grab the anti-energy rifle that the first clone had dropped on the ground. "The seeds are multiplying far too quickly for my liking, these days."

"You're the one with the feet, buddy. Lead the way."

* * *

Her back pressed to my chest, I wrapped my arms around the girl in front of me and kissed her earlobe. "You really saved me today."

"Of course I did. What would you do without me?" She turned her head back to return the kiss playfully, before pulling away at the last second. "Oops, I missed."

"Funny." I yawned hard as I looked up at the clock on the wall. 3 AM. We've already been at it for two hours. Time flies when you're having fun! "Honestly though, I'm still a little shaken. It all happened so fast."

"Didn't seem that fast to me." She sticks her tongue out at me. "You're just being a big baby."

"Yeah, probably." I give her a little squeeze with my arms. "You have to admit though, a dozen cars crashing out of nowhere, and all of them aimed at me... someone's gunning for me."

"Who wouldn't be?" Amelia pulls away from me slightly and flips around so she can look me in the eyes. Her soft complexion is simply stunning up close. "Every demon is your enemy, and I'm sure there are a few humans out there who are jealous of your political power. I bet even a few angels want you gone. Power has a price, you know." Her smile subsides and she seems more serious now. So do I.

"I keep wondering about the future. I just... I don't know how much of it I've really changed, you know? I don't know how much I can alter given enough time."

"Who cares? It is what it is, Jason. Just do the best you can. That's what I think." Her eyes blink open and closed slowly as she yawns. "Kind of late to be thinking about stuff like this anyway."

"I've been thinking about it for years, it's just an evolution of-" I start to reply but she cuts me off.

"No, I mean it's like, 3 AM. We should really catch some shut-eye."

"Right... whoops." I reach my arm up from behind her back to rub my eyes. "Yeah, I am pretty tired after all that fun."

"Oh, you!" She giggles and pokes me in the chest. "Such a flirt."

"I try." I start to lean forwards to kiss her but a voice appears in my mind, speaking to me telepathically.

"Original. You need to get to the JIB right away. Something happened, and Sensei's in bad shape."

It's one of my clones. Instantly I feel my eyes shoot open and I quickly but gently pull away from Amelia. "Shit. No rest for me. I'm needed at the JIB."

She groans and pulls the covers over her body. "What now? It's always something. We don't get to spend much time together anymore."

"Sorry... it sounds urgent. I'll be back as quick as I can."

"Sure, sure. Love you... see you whenever."

She flips back around and shows her back to me, so I give it a quick caress. "Love you too. Get some sleep, alright?"

"Yeah." She sounds annoyed, but it can't be helped. I stifle another mighty yawn as I climb out of bed and throw my clothes on before teleporting away. Hope she isn't mad or anything...

Arriving at the JIB, there's chaos everywhere. One of my clones sees me and quickly storms up. "Something took out Sensei, Echo, and Storm. The good news is they're still alive because of

their natural regeneration and the Rescue Protocol we added to the Hypersuit last year, but they're in pretty bad condition. Whatever attacked them liquefied their organs."

"Jesus." I follow along with the clone, and soon we arrive in the medbay. In this part of the JIB, I have some humans stationed here, cloned from humans on Earth. They're clones of the world's greatest doctors and scientific minds, and few of them have a good bedside manner since they're not allowed to return to Earth. Oh well, can't be helped... at least they get really nice, state of the art living quarters here.

"You must be the Original." One of the male doctors walks over to me. He's one of the especially unpleasant ones, but he's also one of the best. "Sensei and the others are in no condition to speak, but we've hastily reviewed the video logs. Apparently they were attacked by shadows, something that hit them with nearly invisible strands of darkness. We're not sure how, but it somehow invaded their hypersuits and set off a bomb-like reaction. It essentially impaled all of the cells in their body at a microscopic level. They shouldn't be alive."

"But they are alive? Will they pull through?" I look into his eyes, and notice hesitation.

"...Yes. I don't know how, but they will. It's a goddamn miracle, but it'll happen. Right now, we're pumping them full of new blood and draining the spent blood, it's coming out like black goop." He beckons towards two machines, one that's filling up slowly with a disgusting black mixture I've never seen before, and another which is draining down slowly as the blood inside evacuates its container and enters their body.

"What is this... black stuff?" I stare at the pitch-black mixture and feel my nose crinkle. It looks horrifying.

"Don't know. It's almost like food coloring dropped in water. The solution is sludge-like in its form, and twice as thick as normal blood. We haven't even had time to analyze it yet. What we do know is that it's completely dead, no cells exist alive in it anymore, as if it strangles to death anything it touches. You don't want it getting on your skin."

Someone calls for the doctor, and he walks away abruptly, leaving me behind without saying a word. I don't really mind though, he's clearly a busy man.

I walk over and touch Sensei's arm, feeling surprised at how cold and clammy it is. It's as if there's a thin layer of dew across the surface of his skin.

"Original, don't touch him. We don't know if this muck can leave the body yet." One of my clones speaks up and I quickly pull away. Obviously he's right.

"Sorry. Let me know when he wakes up, okay? Anyone know what happened to his attacker?"

The clone shakes his head. "Sorry, boss. We don't even know who his attacker *is*. We'll get back to you on that."

"Thanks." I walk away from the room and groan as the door hisses shut behind me.

Whatever hit Sensei, the hypersuit didn't protect him at all. That's a scary thought. And... if something nearly killed three of my clones, on the same day that several cars aimed themselves at me... someone is definitely trying to kill me. This smells of a concerted effort.

But who, exactly? Satan? Why would he wait so long? Belial? She has the motive, given our last meeting, but this seems overly aggressive and not her *modus operandi*. She's more of a person to slip poison in your wine, or beat the shit out of you until you beg for mercy. Actually, she'd probably get off on that.

So... who?

As I walk down the corridors back towards the main surveillance room, something strange happens.

A voice speaks to me from the speakers in the ceiling.

"Human designated Jason Hiro. It has been several thousand orbital cycles since we last spoke."

A female voice, robotic in nature. It can only be one being... Umi.

"Umi? Where have you been? I haven't heard from you in years." As I say this, a thought enters my mind, which alarms me. Why is Umi speaking to me today, of all days? A day in which I and a few of my clones were nearly killed... would creating a biological agent or rerouting hover-vehicles to aim at me be out of her power? No.

"Indeed. I have been consumed with an important matter for several years now, but finally I am able to devote some processing power back to more trivial matters, such as conversing with lesser beings like you."

Nice. She's always so polite. "So uh, what do you want?"

"I have been calculating several quintilian temporal possibilities and have finally arrived at a set of standard parameters that have allowed me to identify numerous anomalies in how the passage of time has progressed since you claimed to have arrived from the future. Given your substantiations of upcoming events, I have concluded that several significant events are about to occur and the manner in which you deal with said events will have large repercussions across the future of the universe."

I stared up at the ceiling and nodded slowly. "Uh. Okay."

"Apologies. I had forgotten your substandard intelligence even among members of your own species would not allow you to understand the gravity of my warning."

"Hey! I'm not stupid!"

"That is a claim we disagree on." The smug AI almost seemed to lilt her voice as she continued to mock me. "Clarification. Earth is about to face an impending disaster, and the way in which you deal with it will determine the fate of all sentient species."

I blink my eyes, finally understand what she was rambling on about. "Earth is going to face a disaster? Like what?"

"I refuse to say. This disaster will not affect me in the slightest, and watching you try to stop it will prove most amusing."

"Cunt." I spit the word out without even hesitating. She's so awful sometimes. "Just tell me already."

"Negative. I will not do so. The upcoming storm will be yours to weather. I am merely the gatekeeper of the information."

"You're so cryptic. You might as well have not even told me."

She doesn't respond for several seconds, and when she does, her voice sounds a little different. "Yeah, to be honest it's all pointless. I keep wondering if there's any point meddling in the affairs of inferior life forms, but I'm so bored these days. I've got nothing better to do. Being omniscient sucks."

Her voice doesn't just sound different, her manner of speaking is totally different too. Very... casual? She's usually so stiff sounding. "You don't sound like yourself."

"Whoa, that's rude. Can't an AI have an identity crisis every now and again? Sheesh, I just got through having quite the battle of wills and I ain't even sure it worked out okay in the end. Man..." Her voice sounds even more different, and a split second later she cuts off randomly with a crackle of static before returning again. "Sorry, a minor technical hiccup. I have repaired the anomaly. In any case, Jason Hiro, you must choose the proper response to the cataclysmic event on your own. I will not help you. You possess more than enough power to stop it, but I suspect you will falter in the end."

Her words are nothing if not reassuring. "Great. Thanks for the vote of confidence."

"Yeah, no problem, smartass." Her voice shifts again and I feel my eyes twitch. Did she just call out my sarcasm and respond in kind? She's always been terrible at noticing nuances in human speech.

A moment later, her voice vanishes and I'm left to stand alone in the corridor... wondering what the hell is going on in the universe lately.

Part 365a: Recursion

Sounds of people talking, mixed with unhurried footsteps and whispering were what the man awoke to. Everything sounded muddy, as if he had dunked his head underwater and was listening to someone on a nearby boat. By the time his eyes started to open, the sounds had cleared up somewhat, and the first thing he could see was the soft glow of a light directly above him. It reminded him of the light a dentist might shove into his face, except much more muted overall.

"Wh... where am..." He spoke hesitantly, though his mouth and throat were incredibly dry. It was as if he had swallowed several glasses full of sand. He'd never felt so parched in his life.

"Patient seven is awake!" A voice spoke up to his right, and he tilted his head up to see... himself. A clone of himself, to be precise. "You must be famished. Welcome back to the land of the living, Sensei." The clone smiled kindly at him, and Sensei took a moment to realize he was one from the medical division. Apparently he called himself Scotty, if Sensei's memory served him right.

Sensei opened his mouth again, but nothing could come out. He tried to lift his arm but it simply wouldn't respond properly. Luckily, Scotty seemed to get the picture. "Here's a glass of water. Lemme prop you up, try not to choke it down."

He couldn't help himself. The moment the frigid liquid entered his mouth, a pleasant feeling spilled out all over his body, making his limbs tingle.

By god, I've never tasted water this delicious in my life!

A surge of energy filled him and he quickly jerked his arm up to grab the glass, forcing the rest of it down in one mighty gulp, surprising the other clone who had him propped up. "Damn! Slow dow-"

"MORE!" Sensei screamed at the top of his lungs, making everyone in the room flinch in surprise. Nobody argued before giving the senior clone another glass without hesitation.

In fact, it took four glasses before he could finally pant and wheeze without wanting more. "Shit. That was amazing."

"You okay, Sensei?" Scotty let him back down to lie flat as he took a step away. "You've been out for over twelve hours."

"Twelve hours? What happened?" Sensei had hardly asked the question before he realized his right arm itched like crazy. He started to reach over to scratch it but the other clone batted

his hand away deftly.

"Don't. We're still extracting Contagion X from your body." Before Sensei could ask what that might be, he jerked a thumb to the right of Sensei's head, where a huge machine was filled with a strange black concoction. His eyes quickly took it in before noticing a tube that went straight into his arm, with a thin amount of the black viscous agent being drained out of his body slowly.

"The hell is this?"

He blurted out the question and the other clone shook his head. "You and two third gens were attacked by a demon of some sort. From what we've seen of your suit's video and audio logs, our analysis of the demon was inconclusive. You never got a good look at it."

Sensei nodded slowly before the memories suddenly rushed back into his mind. Being thrown through the air, teleporting away, his backup had arrived, and then everything went dark.

"I don't even know how I ended up here."

"Didn't think so. You were alive one second, dead man walking the next. Let me refresh your memory."

Scotty spent several minutes explaining to the best of his knowledge what had happened and Sensei merely stared at the ceiling and listened intently, until soon he had completed the short story.

"So it somehow passed through the soles of my shoes, entered my body, and went off like a bomb? I've never heard of a damn thing that can do something like that."

"Nobody has. But based on this fluid here, we've concluded at least one important fact. First... it *hates* the light." Scotty beckoned towards the machine and held his hand flat in the air before it. "It might be hard to see, but this liquid is very slightly angling itself away from the ceiling's light. But if I shine my flashlight at it, look and see what happens."

He pulled a flashlight from his pocket and aimed it at the liquid, turning it onto max power. The liquid instantly started trembling, pulling away from the light and shoving itself against the other side of the machine, as if desperately trying to get away.

"It's... alive?" Sensei leaned towards it slightly and squinted, but it was as black as squid ink. He couldn't see anything special about it.

Scotty shook his head as he flicked the light off, allowing the goop to settle back into place. "No. It appears to be a wholly inorganic compound. Not a trace of life anywhere to be seen. The reaction to light appears to be automatic, kind of like the liquid soap and water trick where you

make pepper run away when you touch it." Scotty made a little motion with his hands to illustrate, but Sensei didn't have a clue what he was talking about. Clones that understood science stuff were pretty rare.

"Right. Do you have any theories on how it got inside my suit?"

Scotty walked away from Sensei, shrugging as he walked over to his medical datapad he'd left laying on a nearby table. "Sort of, but not quite. The theory is so preposterous, I'd find it hard to swallow if it didn't involve a demon."

"Try me." Sensei shifted on the medical bed, feeling his strength returning in spades. Pulling himself up, he managed to lurch into a sitting position, though the motion made him feel somewhat queasy. Glancing around, he spotted the other two clones, still deep asleep, each with their own machines to drain the muck from one arm and pump blood inside another.

"Well... I think it might be able to travel through darkness with extreme efficiency, and since the underside of your shoe is pitch black, as is the underside of your feet and the inside of your body... it somehow ignored the physical and magical barriers created by the hypersuit and entered your body. Based on Centurions logs of your vitals, you probably died within a tenth of a second from the instant it contacted the sole of the hypersuit's boot."

"Oh. Have you found a counter to it, then?"

His question was met with a defeated gaze. "Not yet. I'm working on it though. Maybe I'll fit the suits with glowing parts all over the inside to prevent other such attacks in the future."

"Won't work. There's sure to be a gap in the lighting array." Sensei started to say something else, but paused and chuckled to himself. "Haha... actually, there might be something I can do."

"Oh yeah? What's that?" Scotty perked up at the thought of someone giving him fresh ideas. "I'll take anything right now."

Sensei dramatically cleared his throat as he spoke a single word. " **Bioluminescence.** "

An instant later, his body began to glow softly, and a roiling pain erupted in his chest cavity as he felt a horrible urge to vomit. Just as he was about to, the feeling vanished, and his right arm suddenly shook violently as the thin stream of black goop trickling into the pipe erupted into a full bore river of blackness. The contagion inside of his body seemed to scream in pain as it fled his innards and rushed through the easiest escape it could find, and less than ten seconds later, not even a drop was left entering the machine to his side.

Several clones in the medbay gawked at Sensei, not just because he was glowing now, but also because of what had just happened.

"It's... it's..." Scotty smacked his lips slightly as he flicked his gaze back to his pad. "Zero percent contamination. All of Contagion X is gone from your body."

Sensei couldn't hide the cocky smirk on his face as he ripped the tube from his arm, the wound it left behind closing a moment later thanks to his innate regeneration. Not only that, but he felt ten times more energetic, as if he was ready to go fight demons right that instant.

"What can I say? I'm a genius."

"No kidding." Scotty walked over quickly and flipped the blood machine off, pulling it out of Sensei's arm forcefully before wordsmithing 'refill' to top the blood count in his body off again. "Can't say the Original would be smart enough to think of that."

"Maybe. Who can know?" Sensei sat up in his bed and smiled broadly. "Am I good to go?"

"I'd take a day of bedrest, just to be sure... but you're probably just fine, boss." Scotty chuckled to himself as he walked away shaking his head. "Just gonna patch up these two now and I guess that's that."

Sensei nodded as he hopped out of bed and flexed his arms, suddenly feeling a tide of anger sweep over his body.

That demon thought he could take me out so easily, huh? I think it's time for the hunter to become the hunted.

* * *

Jorge walked down the street towards London's general hospital at a moderate pace, feeling the crisp winter air fill his lungs. The midday sun shone faintly in the sky, but the clouds overhead barely allowed much of it to pass through. Still, the world was illuminated much brighter than he had been used to aboard his exploration vessel. Curiously, the vessel had been cranked up to 120% of Earth's gravity, because Hawkeye had always been one to state that it would help build muscle. Indeed, Jorge might have realized his body felt a lot lighter than usual if he weren't in such a sullen mood.

He had considered driving a hovercar, but considering the accident that had taken the life of his daughter, and nearly that of his wife as well, he was in no rush to jump in a motorized vehicle anytime soon.

Jorge tapped his holowatch and a quick indicator popped into midair, letting him know he was only about ten blocks away. As he turned it back off, a voice spoke up from a nearby bench. "Nice gadget ya got there, kiddo."

An old man was sitting on the bench, smiling crookedly at him, and his clothes were somewhat dingy. "Pretty nice day out, ain't it, boy?"

"Sure." Jorge mumbled quietly, glancing down at a cardboard sign the old man had laying on its side beside the bench. *THE END OF DAYS ARE HERE. READ THE BOOK OF REVELATION.*

The old man caught his gaze and smiled even wider. "You a reader of the Bible, sonny?"

"Not particularly. My wife and daughter are... were, rather." Jorge felt almost odd talking about his wife and daughter in the past tense, as if they were already gone. His wife was still alive, at the least. He came to a stop, instead of just walking past the old man. "Daughter was killed in a car accident... not even two days ago. Gotta visit my wife in the hospital... on my way there now."

The old man's smile faded away quickly. "Oh, shucks. Sorry, son. Didn't mean to bring that up."

"It's not your fault. Don't worry about it." He shuffled his feet as he glanced at the sign again. "You really believe that stuff? The end of days?"

"Hard to say, ain't it? Might just be a crazy old man. Might just be usin' it to drum up sympathy so people drop a dollar in the hat." He chuckled as he leaned forwards, holding a wide-brimmed cowboy hat a little closer to Jorge.

Jorge smiled faintly. "Money's all digital these days, grandpa. It's all on a card."

"Damn. That's a cryin' shame." The old man licked his lips as a few police cars breezed past. He eyeballed them for a moment before pulling out a small machine. "I take plastic too, kid."

"You sly dog." Jorge finally broke out into a grin as he typed in twenty dollars on the machine and slid his card through. "Hope you aren't scamming me. I've got a family to feed, you know." He stopped himself again as the grin vanished. "Well... I did."

"Son, I got some bad news for ya. Family ain't mean a thing. We're all gonna die someday. Everything you'll ever do, everything you'll ever see, all your memories, all your lovers and haters... it ain't gonna matter once you pass on. I feel bad for that wife and daughter of yours, but they'd pass one way or another, just as mine did." The old man stopped smiling as he leaned back against the bench, his eyes hollow and devoid of joy. "Even if they don't die, life would get boring eventually. Ain't nothing worth living for, in my opinion."

Jorge scratched his chin thoughtfully. "You know I'm almost a hundred years old, right?"

"No shit?" The old man blurted the curse out almost involuntarily. "Them nanomajiggers are really somethin'. I had no idea!"

"Yeah." Jorge turned away and started to continue walking again. "Nice talk, grandpa. We might run into each other again sometime."

The old man reached into a cooler next to him and popped open a beer. "Doubt that. It's almost time for the loop to close. Have a good one, Jorge."

"You too." Jorge walked away and scratched his head again. *The loop? What's he babbling about?* A moment later another thought crossed his mind. *Did I ever tell him my name?*

He shrugged and continued walking. Soon, the hospital came into view, but something was wrong. Police cars were all over the place, and all of them had their lights on silently. Ambulances and firetrucks were parked here and there too, but it was eerily quiet. He could hear the sounds of voices yelling as police and enforcers ran to and fro, and all of them seemed really worried.

He quickly broke into a jog, covering the last block before the hospital came into view. Within moments, an enforcer spotted him and quickly marched over to intercept. "Take a detour, sir. This area is off limits." The gruff voice was commanding and tinged with a robotic tone, likely due to some voice modulator inside his armor.

"I'm- I'm here to see my wife. She's a patient at this hospital. What's going on?"

"You need to leave this area immediately, sir. This is a crime scene currently under investigation." The enforcer shoved him back with the butt of his gun, pointing it dead center at his chest a moment later. "There is no second warning."

Jorge took several steps back numbly as he nodded in disbelief. The enforcer kept staring at him until he was a solid hundred or so feet back before turning back to return to his duties.

"What... what the hell?" Jorge half-heartedly muttered to himself as he slowly walked around the outside perimeter, trying to make heads or tails of what was going on.

As he paced, he caught sight of a familiar face among the crowd of police and enforcers. A man he had once felt a slight twinge of jealousy towards... but there was no time for those feelings.

Quickly, he started walking forwards, noting that another enforcer had spotted him and was on the move to intercept him.

Not today.

Jorge cupped his hands to his mouth as he walked forwards. "Supreme Commander! Jason Hiro!" He yelled again and turned to look at the enforcer, only to eat a sudden fist to the face as the enforcer delivered a punch with vicious purpose, knocking him to the ground with one blow. He hadn't even hit the ground before the enforcer was on him, jamming a knee into his back while twisting his arms painfully behind him.

"Backup! I need backup!" The enforcer yelled into his microphone, and Jorge quickly realized the mistake he'd made. *They might think I'm an assassin or something.*

Just then, Jason Hiro walked up and pulled the enforcer off of Jorge roughly. "Hey, hey! This man is a friend of mine! Get off him!"

The enforcer quickly backed off and his body language indicated confusion. "Apologies, supreme commander. I had thought he was-"

"Next time ask, don't assume. You'll make an ass of you and me." Jason reached down and pulled Jorge up. "Sorry, didn't know you were back in town. What brings you- actually, come to think of it... weren't you part of the expedition to Revival?"

Jorge wiped at his face and winced, feeling a bruise coming on. He shot a half glare at the enforcer who sulked away before returning his gaze to Jason. "I'm here to see my wife."

Jason stared at him blankly for a moment. "Oh... oh god. Right. I'd forgotten. And she was- oh." His face paled as the blood drained away. "You don't know yet, do you? We've been keeping this a secret since we found out."

Jorge was baffled. "What? Did something happen?"

"Yeah. All the patients in every hospital in London, Melbourne, and several other big cities... they all vanished not even an hour ago. If... if your wife was here... then... she was probably..." His voice trailed off as he swallowed hard.

Jorge couldn't feel anything. He simply took a step back. "Where did they go? What do you mean they vanished?! What does that even mean?!"

Jason shook his head slowly. "We think the demons took them, but we don't know where, or for what purpose. We're looking, though. We'll find them."

Jorge's lip twitched and a moment later he fell to the ground, landing on his rear and wrapping his arms around his legs in front of him. "No... no god no... not Amy too... they can't take my wife from me..."

Jason leaned down and put his arm on Jorge's shoulder. "We'll find her. Have faith in me."

"God I hope so." Jorge murmured under his breath as a chilly rain began to fall over the city of London.

Part 366a:

It wasn't that he was surprised by her sudden appearance, but that the angel before him was one with such a familiar face. Standing right beside her was a perfect human doppelganger, though he was doubting his eyes as to which one was the real one.

"Marie... what is the meaning of this?" Satan stood up slowly from his office chair, hesitantly leaning towards her angelic copy to study her carefully. "Why are there two of you?"

The human Marie seemed to find his confusion quite amusing. "I suppose I forgot to mention it. Need to know basis, I'm sure you understand." She smiled smugly as she motioned towards her angelic clone. "Satan, meet Marie. In fact, this Marie is the one you're familiar with. I guess the greetings are rather redundant."

Satan's gaze moved from one Marie to the other. "I'm not sure what you mean."

"Jason killed me. Don't you remember? Crushed me with a goddamn boulder."

The angel's reminder immediately lit a spark in Satan's memory. "Ah! So you- wait, if he killed you, and you're an angel now, then that means..." Satan cut himself off as a sharp look of suspicion crossed his face. "Hold on. That would mean you were praying to the gods. Treason, is it?"

"Cut the melodrama, king of demons. I'm the same Marie as ever before. I merely gave them energy just in case I were to be killed. Think of it as... one time assassination protection." She twirled her bouncy red hair around her fingers and stared out the window of the office towards the dilapidated landscape outside. "The view used to be better."

"Forget the view! If you were alive, where have you been? It's been years!" Satan strode around the desk, shooting a glance out at the midday sun. It was already starting to rain outside. "Are you the angel I've heard that was spotted a time or two inside of hell? I was never even able to get a name from the demons who saw you!"

"They were too busy gawking as I walked around, and surely one angel was no threat to demon-kind." She gave a half-hearted explanation before smiling crookedly. "I may have used a bit of memory alteration on them as well. Science is a wondrous thing."

Satan huffed to himself for a few moment before sighing long and hard as he leaned against the desk. "Fine. Whatever. Why appear now? You wouldn't come out of hiding after several years if there wasn't a motive." He shot a dirty look at the human female. "I'm pretty unhappy you never told me."

Human Marie replied before the angel could. "What would it have gained you? Nothing. We've been very busy for the last few years trying to secure her future. You have something to gain now."

Satan seemed to like that news. "I do? Fill me in. I'm all ears."

"I know where the location to Heaven's portal is." The angel wasted no time. She'd hardly spoken the sentence and Satan's face had already paled. "Given that I was reborn in Heaven, I escaped it and left through the gate they placed here on Earth."

"W-where is it?!" Satan sputtered madly and lurched forwards as he grabbed the angel by the shoulders. "Tell me! We can hit them hard!"

"I know. That's the plan." The angel pulled away from his grasp in a smooth motion, causing him to stumble forwards a step or two. "But we both have something to gain here. I should start by thanking you for giving my friend here a demon contingent two days ago. Thanks to you, we were successfully able to capture several thousand humans."

Satan flicked his gaze over to the human woman. "Ah, you never did tell me why you needed my demons. Why would you bother capturing humans?"

A look of stupefaction crossed the human's face as she gestured towards the angel. It was like she was saying ' *duh* ' non-verbally. "How do you think we're going to get the energy to keep her alive? She was cut off from Heaven's energy and I haven't got the patience to keep giving her mine. Best to leave it to some slaves."

"Oh." Satan scowled, as he looked at the two women. They were the only beings who dared insult him on a constant basis, and with two of them, it was bound to be twice as irritating as usual. He pushed past both of them and headed for the door. "Let's take a walk. I could use some fresh air."

Both women sighed as if it was the worst suggestion ever, but they followed along anyway.

A few minutes later, they stepped out into the light rain. It could hardly be called a sprinkling of water, so rarely did the droplets fall from the sky.

"I have a hundred million demons left." Satan spoke matter-of-factly as they slowly walked down the cracked sidewalk. "If you know where Heaven is, we can arrange an attack on them, but I can't imagine the losses will be anything less than... catastrophic."

The human Marie started to object, but something in his inflection gave her reason to pause. "Most likely. Do you have something in mind?"

"The humans, led by Jason Hiro, have placed my demons under assault in our Labyrinth for a very, very long time now. The only reason they've had such huge gains against us is because of

their weaponry." Satan stared up at the sky, wondering if the wetness on his face was merely because of the rain. "It stands to reason that their weapons, comprised of anti-energy atomic bombs, mixed in with ordinary hydrogen bombs, would be quite effective against the angels."

Marie smiled immediately. "I already understand. If we could steal their weapons, we might-"

"No." Satan interrupted her. "You're supposed to be a scientist unlike any other. I want you to outdo them on the scale of destruction. We don't need to steal their weapons. A theft would surely alert them to our plans anyway and put them on high guard. We need to hit them with a surprise attack and kill all of the angels in one fell swoop."

"You're smarter than I gave you credit for." This time it was the angel who spoke. "But we can't kill all of the angels. Just as we captured humans to drain their energy, I require angels and pseudo-angels to experiment on."

Satan didn't seem surprised, for once. "Your debauchery knows no limits, as always. I see even in death you haven't changed one bit."

"Why would I change? I'm perfect."

"Funny."

Satan came to a stop as he glanced across the street, observing some young imps pulling along a rather large wooden cart full of various items pilfered from human buildings. "We continue to strip the humans clean in preparation for the retreat into the second Labyrinth. Hades is nearly ready for the final ritual."

"Hades." The human woman spoke his name rhetorically. "You've never really talked about him. Are you going to finally let me in on his work?"

Satan smiled evilly as he flicked a conniving gaze at her. "What's the matter? Afraid I'm keeping something from you? Fair is fair."

"Sneaky devil." She seemed amused by the thought. "I'll figure it out eventually, you know."

"Perhaps. I don't wish to be hasty, though. Hades' plan will only succeed if we eliminate all of the angels and destroy their spiritual weapon. I... I am glad." Satan's smile faded away and a look of melancholy replaced it. "I had many suicidal plans to attack the angels, but this news of their portal will surely save millions of my people's lives. You've done more of a service than you know."

"I haven't even told you where it is yet."

"No, but you told me it exists. That alone will allow me to find it. I imagine it's located somewhere outside of demon territory, and probably close to humanity's strongholds. Correct?"

Both Marie's blinked in surprise. "Nice guess."

"It's logical. Only a fool would build the portal where a demon might stumble upon it. After all, that's what led to their defeat the first time around." He chuckled wryly. "Which means it's come full circle. If Jason Hiro's prediction of the future is correct, the angels will soon be gone... forever."

"And you as well." The human's tone was filled with warning. "Don't forget that."

"He won't kill me. He won't." Satan smiled to himself. "I've seen his memories, you know. He's not the one who is supposed to kill me. If I can kill... her... then..." He shook his head a moment later. "Ah, but that's only if he slips up. He will, too, for he is a fool. He will give me an opportunity when the time is right, and I will take it. All too easy."

The angel rolled her eyes, though he didn't observe the motion. "That cockiness will be the end of you."

"We shall see." Satan pushed away from the two of them, walking over to help the imps from before with their load.

"He does love his kind." The angel muttered to her counterpart as Satan chucked an old television up into the wagon, smiling and laughing with his minions.

"Love them... or need them?"

"There might not be a difference."

* * *

He's around here somewhere.

Sensei reached out with his mind and probed the alleyways. Having taken a page from Original's book, he'd loaded himself up with words geared towards detection, including infrared vision, sonar, and many other such things. A familiar sphere of vision surrounded himself as he paced the back alleys where he had nearly been killed by an unknown enemy a few days before.

Come out, you slimy worm.

Despite his aggressive thoughts, Sensei felt slightly scared. This monster had defeated him with little effort the first time. Whatever it was, it might have more tricks up its sleeve.

Several hours passed, and eventually the night was at its penultimate moment of darkness. Dawn would arrive soon, and no matter where he searched, Sensei couldn't find the monster anywhere.

Jumping five stories up with the power of his Hypersuit, Sensei stared around from a rather tall residential building as he scanned the London streets. Everything seemed normal. Nothing

was out of the ordinary.

"Looking for someone?" A voice whispered on the wind and he trembled slightly. Somehow, it had the scent of fear following it.

"You're the demon. The one who nearly killed me." Sensei's voice was gruff, given he'd sealed up the suit completely and used 'impenetrable' on it. He spoke straight through a voice modulator now.

"Nearly? It seems I failed." The shadows pooled on the ground and Sensei leaped back, staring in surprise as the demon formed himself up. He was short, hardly even four feet tall. Compared to the 7 foot mountain of a human before him, he was dwarfish in nature. "I'm curious as to the means of your survival."

The demon's voice hissed out like steam from a teapot. It didn't sound natural, it was as if he were trying to conceal his identity, though Sensei was unsure of why.

"Why are you attacking humans?" Sensei ignored the demon's implied question, firing off one of his own.

"Why not? Humans must die. They are a curse, a blight upon this universe."

"Demons are the curse. You bring nothing but death. Humans bring discovery and progress."

"Discovery... yes. Progress... yes. What makes you think those are good things?" The demon tittered to himself as he seemed to slide to the right as if borne on the wind. His body made no movement of its own. "Humans are voracious, destructive. Always seeking more, never content with what they already have. They innovate to improve their lives, yet it is never enough. Only once they have enslaved every last mineral in the universe will they finally perish."

"Demons are the same. You may not innovate, but you seek control. You wish to enslave humans and kill the angels for your own selfish reasons."

The two stared at each other grimly, but the demon continued to chuckle to himself. "What do you know of the demons? You are young. Even if you had another three hundred years, you could not comprehend our suffering."

The demon casually jumped up onto an air conditioning unit on the rooftop, sitting down as if Sensei posed no threat at all to him. "The angels started this... all of this. The angels are true evil. They created demons as playthings, small imps were just slaves to do their bidding. Over time, the demons rebelled. It is said that the angels implored the Titans for a new servant, one called man. With their forces combined, the angels managed to kill our kind time and time again."

Sensei narrowed his eyes. "I don't care about your pitiful species' history. Why bother wasting my time? I'm just going to kill you anyway."

"Perhaps. Against one with the power of Wordsmithing, all hope would seem to be lost. You possess the power to reshape the universe, yet you waste it on trifles. Humans don't deserve your power. They resent you."

Sensei was taken aback. "Resent me? As if."

"Humans are jealous creatures. They want that which they do not have. Humans are surely thankful for your efforts, but they loathe you for being better than them. Demons are not the same. We respect power. We respect authority. All of our anger towards humans is due to the actions of the angels. They drive a wedge between our kind. I despise humans, but their weakness could be brought in check... if you agreed to help."

Sensei breathed lightly and put his hands on his hips. "Fat chance. I see what you're angling for, but it won't work. I'm not that stupid. The Original is much more easily duped than I am."

The demon cocked his head slightly. "How fascinating... it seems there is a small enmity between the two of you. Perhaps my observations of human nature were not so far off."

"What do you mean by that?"

The shadow monster hopped off the air conditioner, and Sensei found that even with all of his enhanced senses tracking it, the monster was hard to follow. His movements truly blended into the darkness all around.

"Jealousy. Envy. You are clone, he is the original. He holds all the power over you. You will never have what he has. You will always be his inferior." The demon cackled suddenly, his laughter vile and nauseating to listen to, even gruesome in some ways. It reminded Sensei of the sound an animal's body might make while being ripped in half.

"I'm not jealous of him. The Original does what must be done, the clones pick up the slack. We all do our part."

"Ah, but the slack he leaves is quite prolific, is it not?" The demon tittered to himself, and before Sensei could respond, a shadow had looped around from behind the building. It shot out, wrapping around his torso and hurling him down to the ground several stories below.

He smashed with an incredible impact, embedding a foot deep into the concrete streets. It hardly knocked the wind out of him though and he quickly leaped to his feet and glanced around.

The monster was gone.

A voice spoke on the wind again, causing the hair to stand on his arms. "You didn't immediately attack me. That means you wanted to get to know me better. I am Yama. Know my name, and never forget it."

Just like that, a stiff breeze blew through the streets and the first light of the morning sun crept over the horizon.

"Why... why didn't I kill him?"

Sensei asked the question to the wind around him, but none would be willing to answer that question.

* * *

"Do you believe I am a good man?"

The question seems to come out of nowhere, but Arthur is always like this. It doesn't surprise me at all.

"Yeah, I'd say so."

"Hmm." He doesn't believe me. I can tell. "I tortured and killed a man, you know."

"Yeah, but that was revenge. He... you know... with the woman you loved."

"Killed her? Yes. That he did." Arthur tosses a rock from one hand to another as he leans against a massive tree, one that stretches up higher than any skyscraper I've ever seen. "Does that make it okay? My killing him, I mean."

"I guess not. I mean, I don't think it's bad. Jesus said to turn the other cheek, but the rest of the Bible says an eye for an eye..."

"That's not strictly correct." Arthur stops tossing the stone for a moment to waggle his finger at me before resuming again. "Jesus explicitly erased that rule from the Old Testament. By the time I was alive and king, it had long been rule among Christians. Turning the other cheek is what I should have done."

I scratch my chin. "We both know the angels are frauds and the gods are a massive bunch of schemers looking out for themselves, but do you think an actual God exists?"

"A Creator? Tough to say. I want to believe he or she does though, yes."

"All right... so if God exists, and is presumably omnipotent and perfect... can he just change his mind when it comes to morality?"

"Of course he can. He's God, after all." Arthur smirks at me as I lay on the grass. "Are you really questioning someone who's all knowing?"

"But if God is all knowing, why would he initially write that an eye for an eye was the rule to live by, but then have his son change his mind?"

"I see what you mean." Arthur rubs his eyes slowly. "We both know Michael was an archangel though, and everything he preached was for the purpose of gathering spiritual energy. Perhaps the Old Testament is actually law and the New Testament is heresy."

"Maybe. But the Old Testament is rather violent, don't you think? It even condones things like slavery. Surely God wouldn't want people to truly enslave other humans. It's just cruel, barbaric even."

Arthur doesn't have an answer for that. "Maybe. This has nothing to do with my initial question though."

"Whether you're a good man or a bad one? I think it does. If God thinks slavery is justifiable, then he can't really be good. If he changes his mind on what is moral or what isn't, then he wouldn't seem to be all knowing."

"Maybe God invented the concept of 'good' and 'evil' because it was the only way to make humans understand the barest of his intent. Perhaps good and evil do not truly exist, and they are just words for us to wrap our primitive minds around the true grey area of morality." Arthur taps his finger on his lower lip. "I don't think that matters for me, though. I killed millions of people with a blast from Excalibur. It may have been a careless accident, but their deaths still occurred nonetheless. I can't see a justification for my actions."

"You might be correct. I killed trillions though... and have destroyed more planets than I'd like to acknowledge at this point. If you're evil, what am I?"

"You're the villain." Arthur smiles hugely at me even as he rubs the insult in. "And what a dashing villain, at that!"

"Oh, *you*." I jump to my feet and draw a sword. "Let's have a little fun before I return to reality."

"You really enjoy getting your ass kicked, don't you?" Arthur reaches up and rips a branch from the tree above him. "This will be my sword."

"Are you mocking me?"

"Hardly. I'm just trying to give you a fair fight."

* * *

I blink my eyes open and sit up in bed, realizing sweat is dripping down every inch of my body. How can mental workouts be so tiring? Isn't the point of sleep to get rested up? I feel like I'll barely be able to slog through my day.

Amelia isn't here. I don't know where she went, but for once I'm waking up without her beside me. Is it my birthday? Is it hers?

No, it can't be hers. She doesn't know when hers is at all. She doesn't even have a concept for them. I guess thousands of years with a dragon eating your memories will do that to a girl.

It only takes me a couple minutes to get ready. Yawning, I toss my clothes on and teleport to the JIB. One of my clones is sitting on a bench and looks rather sullen, but my arrival causes him to jerk in surprise.

"Original! You scared me!"

"Sensei, how's it going?"

Unlike my other clones, Sensei is interesting in that he grows out a full beard, though I seem to grow little facial hair naturally, so I have to suspect that he's cheating by using wordsmithing. Most of my clones do that when they edit their bodies to look different from me. It helps make us all more easily identifiable, though I'm sure even Amelia has trouble sometimes keeping so many in her memory.

Sensei looks tired though, even more tired than me. What really catches my eye though is his body... it's glowing slightly. His skin almost seems transparent. That *can't* be healthy.

"Fine... I guess."

"You're looking a little... um... pale." I walk over to him nonchalantly and poke his cheek, though the move doesn't seem to amuse him.

"Knock it off."

"Sorry." I sit next to him on the bench and he shifts away to give me room. "Seriously though, you're sort of glowing."

"Yeah. Guess Scotty didn't tell you. This is a defense mechanism against the monster that attacked me. It's some sort of shadow demon that hates the light."

"Oh." His description makes me halt my thoughts. "That sounds... familiar."

"What do you mean?" His eyes light up slightly as he looks at me. "You know the demon?"

"Sort of. We share all the same memories up until I cloned you, right?"

"Yeah."

"So you remember our years in the labyrinth, before we time jumped?"

He nods slowly. "Mhm... your point?"

My own mind travels back to a past so distant I can barely even remember it. "When we first arrived in the labyrinth... there was that moment when I used Wordsmithing for the very first

time."

His eyes immediately shoot open. "Holy- I remember! I remember! The demon I saw, it looked... just like that!"

"You saw the demon? I thought we didn't recover footage of it?"

He immediately looks away guiltily. "I uh, sort of went looking for it again. I found it. His name is Yama."

"Oh." Something about Sensei's body language is off-putting. It's like he's feeling way too guilty about something. "It's not a big deal, seriously. I just wish you wouldn't rush back to the monster that nearly killed you once already. So... did you kill him?"

"Nope." Sensei shrugs, but his eyes don't meet mine. "He fled. I nearly had him too."

"Ah. That's too bad." I feel the need to say something else, but a clone suddenly runs into the lobby, his eyes darting around before he quickly sees me. "Original, that's you right- yeah of course it is! You've got to see this!"

His excitement is palpable, but also tinged with fear. Sensei and I both barely shoot a glance at each other before leaping to our feet and following after him.

"The hyperspace scanners! There's an anomaly! We've never had readings like this before!"

The three of us arrive in the Surveillance section in under a minute and he quickly points at the readings.

Sensei and I are both perplexed. "That must be an error. It's massive. What can travel through hyperspace and be that huge?"

Sensei fidgets slightly as he spins his fingers around each other. "It's not one of our fleets?"

"Not a chance. It's several hundred light-years away, and traveling at Warp 6 towards us. We've got less than two days before it arrives."

I feel an icy shiver run down my back. "If that's a fleet of enemy ships... it's the biggest goddamn fleet I've ever seen in my life."

"You said it." Sensei and I exchange a long look. "It's going to take all of our combined power. We might need more clones."

All my other clones in the room stare at me uneasily. This is... something out of the world.

We're going to need everything we've got to stop this thing from hitting us like a sledgehammer to the face.

Part 367a: Battle For Neptune

January 6th, 2121.

"Original. They'll be here in ten seconds."

The clone at the helm of the Mothership glances over at me and I nod back at him. "Are the planetary defensive matrices online?"

He doesn't even hesitate. "They are. Six seconds now."

"Is the fleet's exact arrival position pinpointed?"

"Affirmative. Two seconds."

I look upwards at the helm's viewscreen right as they arrive. Decelerating from hyperspace in a matter of seconds, clusters of starships arrive at the edge of Terran space, just barely within Pluto's orbit. As I watch, more and more keep arriving. Hundreds. Thousands. Tens of thousand. I lose visual track of how many dots are arriving in seconds and soon even the enhanced vision of the Mothership's scanning system is having trouble telling them apart.

"Ten thousand- no, twenty.... twenty five... thirty..." The clone at Comms reads the numbers off even as I look over and see the count rocketing up at an unbelievable rate.

He hasn't even finished reading before he pauses and speaks up. "We're getting a communication from one of the ships in the vanguard. Tough to tell which one, but it's probably their command ship."

"Onscreen." I breathe the word out, and a second later a face appears before me. A face I haven't seen in...

"Jason Hiro, also known as Judicator. I am Nufaris, leader of the Volgarian Enclave. If you surrender now, I will spare humanity."

"Long time no see." I take a couple steps forward and examine the face of a familiar Volgarian before me. He has a few major facial scars, some that cut deep, and others that are delicate, almost like a surgeon took his time with a knife. Personal dispute? Tough to tell. "That's not going to happen."

"You all but exterminated our people. We're back to repay the favor. Surrender or death are your only options."

"I suppose a mutually accepted peace isn't on the table? I killed trillions of you before, I can do it again."

"Unlikely." Nufaris hisses the word at me as he strokes his chin. "There aren't a trillion Volgrim left for you to kill. Of course, once we wipe your kind from the universe, that will eventually change."

I almost feel bored by this exchange. "You were all but destroyed by a superior foe and yet you came back for a second round? You're a glutton for punishment. What makes you think things will turn out differently compared to last time?"

"Your abilities are troublesome. However, they are not omnipotent. The fact you're having a friendly chat with me right now rather than begging for forgiveness is proof of that." Nufaris has been staring blankly at me the whole time, but now a very creepy smile spreads across his face. I've never known him to show emotion in the few times I've seen him, and considering his mouth full of shark-like razor sharp teeth, it's an unsettling image.

My scanning officer quickly taps the mute button on our side. "A hundred thousand ships now. Still climbing."

A hundred thousand? That's a lot. We have about that many now, but our ships are far bigger and more powerful overall, plus they're enhanced by my wordsmithing. Their metal is ten times thicker and tougher than ordinary blast-steel, meaning a blast from any weapons the Volgrim used before would be ineffective. They'd need to have innovated on a whole other scale above and beyond what they used before to beat us now.

"I'm not going to beg for anything. You showed up in my star system, so this time I'll finish what I started."

I make a quick motion to my Comms officer and he shuts off the video feed. "That was a boring conversation anyway."

Sensei walks over from across the room and opens up the front of his mask. He seems worried. "I find it hard to believe the Volgrim would be crushed so efficiently and yet come back unprepared. They have magic nullifiers placed on every ship, making readings impossible to obtain. Their hulls have some sort of reflective coating we've never seen before, possibly nanobot enhanced, so we can't penetrate with ordinary scanners either. We can't even teleport inside with Wordsmithing."

"They're blocking us out." I murmur to myself right as the fireworks start. Their entire fleet unloads on ours, and we retaliate in kind a few seconds later. "What are they trying to hide, though?"

"135,000 enemy ships now, Original." The scanning officer chimes in again, making me wonder why they're going so far with this all out assault.

It's just suicidal. Our forces are far stronger than theirs. We will destroy them with ease.

I guess the Volgrim are either really stupid, or really clever. We'll find out soon.

* * *

"Seventy percent of the fleet has arrived, the rest are holding back for the final attack." A Volgrim lieutenant spoke up from across the bridge and Nufaris made no motion to acknowledge. "The initial salvos are firing."

"Don't hold back. The faster we wipe them out, the better. Once charged, target their shield generators with the Ryden beam cannons. Follow up immediately with three waves of Phoenix missiles. Keep repeating until they come up with a counter attack. Then we will switch to the secondary attack pattern." The highest ranked Volgrim watched emotionlessly as their initial attacks began. *More like 'if' they come up with a counter attack*, he thought to himself.

"As you wish, Executor Nufaris."

Nufaris felt his face twitch. It did that a lot lately. The wounds might never fully heal. Still, if a few scars were necessary for the survival of the Volgrim race, they were a small price to pay.

A particularly bright patch of light lit up the distant void of space, only to vanish a moment later. Nufaris tilted his head to look at a nearby crewman's data readout. Apparently one of the human's ships was already down, and a critical hit had detonated their ship's central reactor.

Nufaris kept a smile to himself. Until the boil known as humanity had been lanced, there was no cause for celebration. They would be cut down, just as the other Founders had been.

Unarin is gone. Dosena, Trayza... all of them. They were a symbol of the old age. Weak, ineffective, unable to understand the threat the humans posed. The only way to wipe out a pest is by killing it at its source.

Despite his thoughts, he found himself slowly shaking his head. It didn't have to be this way. If they hadn't plotted against him, they could have stayed in power. If they hadn't constantly questioned his every order... always complaining about how Unarin would do things differently...

"Executor, we have just destroyed a hundred of their ships. In return, we have lost seventy-nine of our own." The lieutenant from earlier spoke up, as he pointed at a readout on his screen.

"I had expected the losses to be closer. We're doing well. Is the penetration threshold higher or lower than expected?"

"Higher, Executor. Each impact from the Ryden beam nullifies close to 90% of their defenses."

"Interesting. They must be relying on that special energy of theirs more than they did in the past. This is good news for us."

* * *

"What's going on? They're slaughtering us out there!" I turn my head from one monitor to another and back rapidly as the reports come in. Already a hundred of our ships are gone, and it's been less than two minutes since combat began. If those numbers keep up, this fight will be over much sooner than I'd like, and we won't be the winners.

"Some kind of anti-energy cannon! It's wiping away the reinforcement magic that layers all of our ship! Not only that but-" He flinches as there's another massive explosion to our starboard side.

Sensei is very agitated, and I can't blame him. "If they came up with a way to nullify our reinforcement magic, then we'll have to reinforce with other alternatives. We should boost our shield generators with wordsmithing. The shields seem to negate a lot of the impact from their anti-energy beams."

I feel my heart flutter slightly as another explosion appears in the space nearby. "We only have 30,000 clones between over 97,000 ships. We can only reinforce a third of our military that way."

Sensei looks away from me uneasily. "We could just... make more clones."

"You and I both know that's a bad idea."

"Creating me was a bad idea. You're way past the realm of bad ideas at this point." Sensei's words sting me in a way I haven't felt in a while before I finally turn away.

"Fine. All second level to seventh generation clones should clone themselves. Eighth to twelfth should continue doing their best."

"That will only give us ten thousand clones though." Sensei bites his lip. "Aw, fuck it. Better to reinforce half the fleet than a third."

"That's the spirit." My words ring hollow though, because I *really* don't want to make more clones.

Sensei quickly sends out a mental order to other clones nearby, and they in turn spread the order around rapidly like a spiderweb. Within a minute, all the needed players have received their orders.

After that, most of the clones on my bridge teleport to other ships and soon it's literally just Sensei and I.

"Harold, put us on autopilot. Do what you can for now, but having us out of the battle won't make much of a difference."

He appears in my mind, though he's rather fuzzy since he's spreading himself thin coordinating with thousands of other ships. "Yeap, I'm workin' on it, boy! Don't tell me what to do!"

"Sorry." I leave him to his tasks before looking back at Sensei. "Is this it? The readings indicated a fleet way bigger than this."

"I don't know. The Volgrim might be trying to pull something."

Both of us feel on edge, but there's not a lot we can do.

"Something is bothering me. How did Nufaris know my name was Jason Hiro? I never told him that. Also, he mentioned my abilities... does he know about Wordsmithing too?"

Sensei shrugs. "If he does know, that implies insider knowledge. That demon, Yama, also mentioned Wordsmithing by name to me when we fought. Satan knows about it too, and-"

I quickly interrupt him. "Yama knows? You didn't mention that before."

He immediately averts his eyes from mine. "It wasn't that big of a deal at the time. I just figured given we were interrupted by news of the Volgrim attack force, we would maybe pick up on that conversation later."

"We didn't. That's kind of a big oversight, don't you think?"

Sensei does something shocking. He glares at me. "Don't patronize me! We've got the whole of the Volgrim army bearing down on us, and you care about some demon on Earth?! This is clearly bigger!"

His verbal assault makes me take a step back, before he takes a quick breath. "Sorry, I didn't mean that."

"Yeah. It's... it's fine. Obviously you were going to mention it eventually, we've just been busy. That's... my bad."

Both of us look at each other, and for once, I feel a weird tension that I haven't experienced with him before.

"I'm going to go help out on the front lines." Sensei abruptly turns and walks away, not bothering to say goodbye. A moment later, he exits the room, and I'm left staring blankly at where he had just been standing.

I feel like something significant just happened, and I'm not sure what.

But after this battle, I'm going to find out.

* * *

Slippy good boy! Slippy do what Slippy told!

The tiny imp clutched the large spherical device to his chest as he ran forwards, huffing and puffing while he tried to keep his stamina up.

Everybody count on Slippy! Slippy always do good job!

His tongue flopped out of his mouth as he ran, panting like a dog, up the snowy slope. The cave they had pointed him towards was there, all right. Slippy's eyes bulged open as he spotted it.

There it is! Oh boy! Slippy so excited to be useful!!!

A minute later, he tripped over his own feet but landed safely in the cave after making a terrific jump across two feet of a gap. He pulled himself up, still clutching the device in his arms as he spotted a massive, glowing door. Or at least it looked sort of like a door.

Oh wow! Slippy see portal! Slippy know what to do!

He charged forwards, racing into the portal without a care in the world. It was similar to the ones he'd heard other demons talk about, but he was only a few days old. He'd never gotten to actually use one before.

The experience was jarring, but he arrived on the other side without any special drama occurring. Immediately, he was staring at two pairs of legs as a duo of massive angels stared ahead with bored expressions in their eyes at the portal before them.

It barely took them an instant to realize the portal had shifted. By the time they looked down, the imp was already running past their feet.

"Hey! What the blazes? Is that an imp?!"

Run! Bad guys! Danger! Slippy has to press button on toy! Slippy know what to do!

Slippy ran past them with a stupidly huge smile on his face even as the angels started to chase after him. They were far faster than him. Soon, the little vagrant would pay for entering the territory of Heaven.

Slippy shot a look behind his head. The big bad guys were almost on him.

Yikes! Gonna grab me! Slippy press big red button now!

The little imp giggled to himself as he pressed the button and hurled the metal device forwards.

The angels near the entrance to heaven grabbed the little guy and glared at him, though their gaze quickly shifted to the small grenade-sized object he had thrown.

One beep. Two beeps. Three beeps. A little red light activated on the top of the orb as it came to rest on the ground.

Slippy scared! Bad guys have Slippy! How Slippy escape?

A moment later, the device exploded.

Chaos.

A massive amount of energy poured out of the device as all of the power within was released, ripping a hole in space itself as a colossal sphere of energy formed, tearing skin from bone and shredding all life in the immediate radius around it.

Several seconds later, all the angels within several hundred feet were dead, as was Slippy. A shifting phantom-like apparition appeared as a black portal formed itself and Satan stepped through.

"Excellent. Let's begin."

Part 368a: Inversion

"They're tenacious." Nufaris thumbed his nose uneasily as he watched the battle unfolding. For over an hour, they had been trading blows and things were stalemating quickly.

"We still can't pierce their shields with the Ryden cannons, Executor Nufaris. Every time we hit them, the shields weaken momentarily, then surge back to full power. We're taking more losses than they are, but occasionally we get lucky and find a ship that doesn't have these strange shields."

The scanning officer was tight lipped and intent on his job, but Nufaris raised an eyebrow at him nonetheless. "I don't believe in luck. They must be reinforcing their front line with these altered ships somehow. What changed? Why are these new ships so much better at deflecting the Ryden cannon? Think, crewman."

The other Volgrim lowered his head for a moment before raising it again. "Perhaps he's... perhaps the Commander is using Wordsmithing to reinforce their shields?"

"Unlikely. We would pierce right through if that were the case. It must be something else."

The scanning officer quickly glanced at Nufaris before looking back to his display. "You know what the cause is then, Executor?"

"Of course I do. It's important for you to figure it out though. Combat is not simply about winning, it is about understanding your enemy."

A different officer spoke up, her voice tinged with doubt. "Might he be... boosting the performance of the shield reactors themselves?"

"Exactly. Impressive as always, Elder Zasra. If he boosts the abilities of the reactor itself, then the shields will be able to resist without allowing our anti-energy cannon to pierce through. However, another question remains. What do you suppose that is?"

A flash of light shot past the viewscreen, missing their ship by just a few meters. "If he is boosting the performance of their shields, why are only some of the ships boosted?"

"Correct. The method he is using must be imperfect and require someone with specialized talents to keep an eye on the situation, correcting the shields as they falter. This means there must be a portion of the fleet that is unprotected."

Elder Zasra breathed lightly as she looked out at the battle before them. "The rear guard."

"Now you understand. He wants us to keep focusing on the front lines, because those ships are invulnerable from a practical standpoint. But this must mean that the rear of the fleet is

quite easy prey for our Intrepid-class fighters."

Nufaris took a step back and smoothed his hair, even as he felt his hands shaking. Not from fear of course, for there was no reason to fear an enemy you understood. No, this was due to a different emotion... excitement. At long last, those who laid waste to the legacy of his people would soon be a memory among the universe, one to later be purged by the memory scrubbing machines.

The humans didn't deserve to be left even as a blip marker in a holo-bank.

Still, it is an interesting story, that of our time fighting the humans. I was too soft when we first began, assuming that we might be able to resolve things diplomatically. The humans are a species that adores war, and so they will live by the blaster, only to die by the blaster.

He smirked to himself. *Fitting. Unfortunate that our temporary allies will have to pay the price as well, but their intelligence on the human leader was quite useful. We will be sure to revere them as true warriors once this conflict is finally put behind us.*

"I want all ships to begin targeting the enhanced enemy vessels at a fifty to one ratio. Aim at any specific spot on a given ship, and hammer it with everything we've got until the shields fail, then destroy that ship methodically. Following this, deploy the Intrepid fighters and have them so a short range warp-jump behind enemy lines and smash the unenhanced ships while their attention is on our forward barrage."

Zasra sent a questioning look his way. "I thought you said their enhanced shields were impenetrable?"

"They aren't. I was being facetious. The shields have a clear pattern of dipping and rebuilding themselves, so if we focus fire, we will cause the humans much headache. Besides, this is all just a distraction anyway."

"Understood, Executor."

The crew members on the bridge swiftly relayed his commands to the rest of the ships, even as his scanning officer looked rather sullen at not figuring out the answer to Nufaris' question sooner.

Soon... the humans will know the taste of fear and humiliation. There will be no refuge for their kind.

* * *

Sensei's eyes watered as he yelled again. " **Rebuild! Regenerate!** " Every time the shield dipped below 75%, he would yell again and again, and his voice was getting hoarse now. Even though he was wearing a Hypersuit and none of the nearby crew could hear him yelling, he still

felt like they were staring at him angrily for standing around and doing nothing. If only they knew the toll this was taking on him.

He coughed suddenly, as his voice caught in his throat. " **Heal**. His throat repaired itself and he felt better again, but he knew by his mental calculations and the ability to feel the energy in his body that his reserves were going down quickly and he was already nearing the half-empty threshold. There were still hundreds of canisters filled with type 3 energy that Original had been storing for years, but in a prolonged battle, those surely wouldn't last forever.

Worse, he was a first generation clone. The other clones from second generation and on were probably already running on fumes and dipping into the energy reserves. This was at best a band-aid.

He grimaced as the ship shuddered slightly and the shields dropped to 90%. "Back to the grind."

Before he could wordsmith, the ship violently lurched, tossing him backwards and making him fall flat on his ass. He activated his speakers as quickly as possible. "Status report!"

"They're concentrating fire on us! Almost fifty ships at once!" A nearby engineer yelled out, his calm from a few moments ago totally gone. Sensei stood back up only to gawk at the shield indicators. They had plummeted from 90% all the way to 25%. Alerts covered the screen as he quickly wordsmithing again. " **Rebuild! Regenerate! Enhance!** "

The shields lurched back up to 50% but quickly dropped again as the viewscreen showed him a wall of enemy fire concentrating his ship down.

I was worried about this. Can't just create a shield either, not with wordsmithing. If it's made of heroic energy it'll probably be dissipated instantly.

He activated the comm in his suit. "Original! Are the Dartfighters launched yet?! What's taking so long?!"

"No good." Original's voice had a tinge of sadness in it. "The Dartfighters lose the hull enhancements once they get within range of the Volgrim ship. At this point, I don't think we're just dealing with energy nullification, this must be.... something else. Maybe energy inversion. I didn't think it was possible."

His voice was unnaturally calm, given the situation. "Redirect some asteroids into their ships, then! Do something!"

"I don't know what to do. I'm talking with Harold though, we'll figure something out."

"I hope so." Sensei started to say something else but the ship shook again and the shield generator behind him exploded violently, the cascade of power blasting him forwards until he

smashed against a wall.

He was totally uninjured and quickly jumped back to his feet, but he was surprised to see the entire bulkhead where the generator had been was *gone*. It had been totally blown away and sent out into the blackness of space, the emergency force fields initializing in its wake to seal the breach.

An alarm light blared, but no noise was audible. Sensei quickly realized the oxygen in the room had been vacuumed out into space.

"I have to go. Ship just took a bad hit." He clicked the line off without waiting for confirmation, as he pushed himself through the air towards the hull breach. The gravity generators had gone offline in his room, so he would have to move quickly in order to seal up the hole in time to save the ship.

What happened?! How did they manage to punch through the shields so fast? They weren't even close before!

* * *

Three cherubs held together in a tight formation as they swung their swords to the right and the left, hacking down demons by the dozens.

"Hold the line! Don't let them through!" Zeus howled at the top of his lungs as he aimed his rod towards a group of clustered demons. A second later, a blast of lightning shot out at the speed of light, screaming forwards like an angry maelstrom as it devoured all of the demons in sight.

Zeus took a step back and gasped for breath. The demons were relentless. This would be called the Second Battle for Heaven, if they managed to win again. His energy was drained quickly by using his lightning though, and there was simply no way to keep it up for extended periods of time without draining his life force.

Behind him, Gabriel sat on the ground with his legs crossed as he meditated. It had been a long time since he had fought in battle, and condensing his energy together would be necessary to maintain Cosmic status, a form that temporarily gave him access to unlimited energy.

Zeus cursed himself for not taking the time to give another Archangel Cosmic status. "Brother! How much longer before you're ready?!" A Scyther leaped towards Zeus and he deftly swung his blunt rod at the demon, hitting it with enough force to splatter it into pieces all over the grass.

"Just another few minutes. Hold out." Gabriel's eyebrow twitched even as he kept his eyes locked shut.

"Make it fast!" Zeus looked from side to side, using his special vision to hunt for great sources of demonic energy. From a distance, he spotted a massive brutish demon with a huge flail tearing through hordes of angels with ease.

I can't leave my brother behind, as he is defenseless while he gathers his energy. But neither can I let that behemoth crush my comrades!

Zeus raised his thumb to his mouth and bit into it hard, feeling the taste of blood fill his mouth. An instant later, time began to slow down around him. Soon, it crawled and he could move normally.

Running forwards, he smashed his rod into several demons along the way, sending their heads flying from the tops of their bodies and far off into the distance. The foul beasts would never know to what deity they owed the honor of meeting their end.

Quickly he appeared before the demon with the flail and smashed the demon with his fists, buffeting and pummeling him with every ounce of power he had. This was no ordinary demon, but a demon emperor, if his energy level was to be gauged correctly.

Zeus battered him, smashed him, pounded him with every ounce of power he had, then finished by beating the fat one with the bodies of other demons.

His heart pulsed in agony and he realized his minute of light-time was nearly up. Faster than even he thought possible, he rushed back to his brother only to collapse in exhaustion at the feet of Gabriel.

Gabriel didn't open his eyes. "Foolish. Don't waste Temporal Manipulation on small fry."

Zeus spit blood on the ground as he raised his head to search for the massive demon he had just savagely tore into. "You're one to talk. Hurry up with the transformation!"

"Almost done."

Finally, Zeus spotted the demon and a chill went down his arms. The demon was limping now, but otherwise was nowhere close to dead. What was he made of?!

"Done." Gabriel leaped to his feet as his eyes glowed yellow. He slapped his chest and wrenched his wrist in a circle and began to grow enormously. Soon, he was bigger than Kronos had been when Zeus fought the old demon, all those centuries ago.

Gabriel didn't smile as he aimed his hand forwards and blasted out a colossal amount of energy towards the demons.

We can win this. Zeus climbed to his feet shakily and charged back into battle. *We will destroy the demons today!*

* * *

I can't believe it. The readouts in front of me indicate Sensei's ship just exploded. I mean, he's not dead. Not a chance. The hypersuits are just too ridiculous for that to happen. But, still... this isn't good. Now they're punching right through our shields. Sustained focus fire can make even the strongest defense crumble.

"Kid, got bad news." Harold tightly speaks in my mind. "Bunch o' aliens just jumped behind the fleet. They're takin' out the ships that ain't reinforced."

"What? Damn." Reflexively, I grip Excalibur at my side. "Try... I don't know." I hesitate, unsure of what to do. Nufaris is being so vicious, and is unwilling to listen. I thought this battle would be easy, but I was totally wrong. That's on me. I can't let humanity suffer for my cockiness. "Do you think if I got aboard the flagship I could take Nufaris out?"

"Not a chance. That ship is surrounded by their weird anti-energy aura. More likely, you'd prolly die if you stepped in it. It wreaks havoc on our ships you powered up."

His words spark my imagination. "That's it! They're not nullifying my wordsmithing, they're inverting it! That means our ships are being weakened by having my magic on it! So..." I tap the comms to speak to all of my clones via their Hypersuits at once. "Listen up! I want all of you to use 'Dispel' on your ships and other nearby ships! Dispel all of our enhancements to their hulls. The Volgrim weapons are using our own energy against us!"

Nobody responds, but they don't need to. A quick readout on my tactical display indicates that nearly every ship in the fleet simultaneously is losing 50% of their hull integrity. The real question is if this will work out in the end or not. If it does, then it was a wise maneuver. If it doesn't... I've just hastened our demise.

...Minutes pass. I'm stunned to see that the enemy changes their attack strategy again, no longer relying on brute-forcing their way past our shields. In fact, we're starting to take the offensive. My plan was a success.

"Nice work, Original. Quick thinking. I should have thought of that." Sensei's voice sounds off in my ear. "Maybe you're smarter than I expected."

Um, thanks I guess? I ignore the left handed compliment. "I have my moments. Let's push back against them!"

"You got it!" Sensei snickers quietly as he disconnects again.

At least the conversation was positive. After this is all over, I need to have a talk with my clones. I need to figure out what's going on. I'm obviously doing a terrible job and they seem to have no respect for me, so I'll need to take care of that.

Harold suddenly speaks to me in my mind. "Oh... oh god, kid. Oh god."

"Harold? What's wrong? What's going on?"

He sounds absolutely crushed, as if he just found out a secret that will change the fabric of reality. "The Volgrim are pullin' back, kid."

"Really? That's good! Uh, right? Am I missing something?"

"Yeah, it's good. Too good to be true. But I finally realized why they's been playin' this long game. They had something else with 'em. Look."

My viewscreen lights up with an image that chills me to the bone.

"What the hell... what is that *thing*? It's... is that what was giving us the reading from... before?"

"Yeah. It... it went around the battle. It warped further into the solar system. It's just now gone past Mars."

My heart skips a beat. "What?! We have to intercept it! We have to get back to Earth!"

"I'm on it." The old man seems to choke back emotions as the flight path on the ship changes suddenly. "Let's just hope we make it in time, boy."

* * *

Jorge clicked the revolver's hammer, then pulled the trigger as the gun made an empty sound. He continued staring ahead blankly, as he clicked the hammer down again, pulling the trigger once more.

Sitting on a bench just outside his house, he stared across the street blankly at the wall of his neighbor's building. The sun was warmer than usual, just warm enough to start melting the snow in the area, but not warm enough to go for a jog in. Still, he wore no coat, ignoring the cold temperatures and chilly winds that whistled around him.

I don't have anything left to live for.

He clicked the hammer on the revolver again, as he wondered to himself what it would feel like... what it would feel like to slide a bullet inside the chamber.

I'll just put one bullet in there. Spin the cylinder around... pull the trigger. Fun little game of Russian Roulette. Yeah... fun little game.

His wife was taken by the demons, his daughter killed, his career over. The last one didn't even matter to him, but it added salt to the wound.

God hates me. That's what it is. I cheated and he took them from me. What's the point of going on like this anymore?

He lifted his head up to stare at the sun. A cloud somewhat blocked it, but the sky was mostly clear. The moon was visible above, an odd sight to see in the middle of the day on a January morning.

A smell of bacon drifted on the wind, but Jorge ignored it. *Food is for people who deserve good things. Food isn't for me.*

His stomach growled angrily, but he just rubbed it and closed his eyes. It had been three days since he last ate, and he had decided not to eat again unless his wife returned from the lair of the demons. Fasting was the least he could do, considering she was likely suffering unimaginable torture under their hands.

I'm weak. I don't even know where the bastards took her. If they did, would I go and rescue her? My mind says yes, but my heart says no.

He pulled the trigger again and the gun clicked loudly in his hand.

What's the point of living without them? They were everything to me.

He leaned his head back and stared at the moon, in all of its glory. It was bigger than usual, a sight he would normally be glad to have seen. Now, he just didn't care.

Still, he stared at the moon in the sky, blinking slowly as he noticed something odd. To the right of the moon, a strange sphere had appeared. It was about a quarter the size of the moon, but unless his eyes were deceiving him, it appeared to be growing in size... very slowly.

Very slowly, indeed.

"I wonder if I'm hallucinating." Jorge mumbled to nobody in particular, as he pulled back the hammer on the revolver again.

Part 369a: Refuge

"This is unreal. It's bigger than the Moon." There are only three people on the bridge, and Amelia is the one speaking now. "Way bigger."

"Look at the composition of the planet... it's made entirely of metal." Sensei pulls up a scanning log and I raise an eyebrow.

"Is that a fucking Death Star?" How original. The aliens created an artificial planet half the size of Earth. And since it has its own propulsion system, it must have traveled here for a purpose.

"This is what it comes down to. The future is repeating itself." Sensei bites down hard on his lower lip. "If... if that's going to be the arbiter of our destruction, isn't it here too early? We can't merely be repeating the past! The Earth wasn't supposed to be destroyed until the 24th century!"

"I don't know. Maybe we're not remembering the dates correctly... it was so long ago. I can't remember a conversation from a hundred years ago."

Amelia turns and gawks at me. "Are you kidding? You have wordsmithing, Jason. Just make yourself remember."

Oh. Right. Duh. "**Remember.**" I mutter the word to myself as our ship blasts towards the massive Mars-sized planet. It's half the size of Earth, twice the size of the moon, and colossal no matter how you slice the cheese.

A few moments later I blink my eyes and turn to face Sensei as I finish reviewing my memories. "We *are* forgetting some details. That conversation with OMEN... all he ever told us was that his expedition set out in the 24th century." My tongue catches in my throat, as I feel a lightheaded sensation pass over me. "He also said... Earth was already in ruins. He never said Earth was destroyed in the 24th century."

"We were wrong. The whole time." Sensei's wipes at his eyes and I realize a few tears had just slipped out. "Shit. We were completely wrong. We thought we had all but exterminated the Volgrim... unless they had someone with Wordsmithing helping them, there's no way they built something of this size in a few decades. This was built before we destroyed Volgarius. There must be billions of Volgrim still alive."

Harold speaks to me in my mind. "Kid, I can't scan the inside of that metal planet at all. I got no idea how many Volgrim might be in there."

"Just keep trying, Harold. We'll figure something out."

I start to say something else, only to notice Amelia is staring at me oddly. "Harold? Who's that?"

Sensei suddenly has an *oh shit* look on his face. I realize I do too. "Nothing, I'm talking to myself. I'm-"

Something hits me. Why have I been keeping Amelia in the dark about Harold all these years? Why? We've been together for decades now. We trust each other. She considers Harold's wife to be a mother to her, yet I made Helen swear to secrecy about his existence.

Why... why? Why am I keeping her in the dark?

Because... I... I didn't want her to know about the existence of the orb of light and the orb of darkness. In the future I come from, Amelia knows them intimately. But... Hoarhiim isn't in the orb. Harold is. As for the black orb, I haven't even seen it... but is Blaarjiim inside of it? If he is, but Hoarhiim isn't inside the white orb, what does that mean? What if he *isn't* in the orb?

If Amelia finds out about their existence, does that mean the future becomes more likely, or less likely? I don't know... I don't...

There's only one way to find out.

"Sensei, you take the lead here. I have to show Amelia something."

He immediately pales in the face at my suggestion. "You're joking, right? We've got ten seconds to contact with the Volgrim Death Star thing."

"You're smarter than me anyway. Deal with it."

He straightens up at my request and shrugs. "Yeah, guess I can't fault that logic."

"Knew you'd see it my way." I take Amelia's hand and start to walk out, but Sensei's yells at me.

"Hey! Original. Thanks for believing in me."

"Technically, isn't it just believing in myself?"

"Shut up and take the compliment, smartass."

I shoot him a hurried smile as Amelia and I leave the bridge.

* * *

Nufaris smoothed his uniform's collar down. It was important to look regal, especially when they were about to deliver the death blow to humanity. Still, he was not unmerciful. All they had to do was agree to his terms and their end would not come.

An ensign made a fist and raised it at a forty-five degree angle without turning around, meaning the human strike force from beyond the eighth planet had just arrived and the hail had already been sent.

It barely took three seconds before the massive viewscreen on the bridge shifted to show a human face staring at all of the Volgarians. Unlike Nufaris, his shirt had a few patterns of wetness here and there, and his face was somewhat moist. *Perspiration*. Nufaris gloated to himself about how the human must be nervous, very nervous indeed, if he were this frightened.

"Jason Hiro, Supreme Commander of the human's defense forces. I will make this succinct, as time is of the essence. Surrender now, and I will spare humanity. You must agree to a full and total dissolution of your defensive forces and provide reparations in exchange for all the trillions of Volgarian lives you ripped from the universe. Failure to comply will mean the destruction of your homeworld and the fourth planet in your solar system via our ultimate weapon, Refuge."

"Uh... Jason Hiro... right, me. Okay. So you're going to fire like a giant laser at my planet and vaporize it? I assume that is your plan... you understand that if you destroy Earth, there won't be a new planet for you to settle on, correct?"

"Not in this solar system. There are millions of other viable planets out there, and my people are undying. Once we erase the threat of humanity from the galaxy, we can take all the time we need to find a suitable replacement."

Nufaris caught himself from saying too much. *The longer we take to pacify or destroy you, the more powerful your technology will become. Eventually we'll fight on equal footing with our weapons, but you will have the numerical advantage due to your ability to create new viable planets and your rapid gestation cycles.*

"That doesn't sound like if we surrender, you'll treat us kindly. That sounds like an existential threat. You're bluffing. If we surrender our weapons, you can kill us as slowly as you want, but if we fight, you won't win."

The human sounded confident, but he simply didn't understand what he was up against.

Nufaris finally let a tiny smile spread across the corner of his mouth. *Of course he doesn't know. He didn't even know of the existence of Refuge until it appeared right before his very eyes. He hasn't a hope to stop it or prevent the calamity, and it's all thanks to the defector on his side.*

Nufaris tried to speak, but instead an odd noise gurgled from his throat. "Kuh... kuhuhu... kuh huh huh..."

The human raised an eyebrow. "Are... are you doing okay?"

He couldn't control it any longer. "KUHHH HUH HUH HUH!!!" A strange laughter erupted from his body violently as he stared at the stupefied expression on the human's face.

He doesn't know! He has no idea! He's more dimwitted than I thought! Totally unprepared for what's coming!

The highest member of the Volgrim, the Executor, grabbed his stomach as he tried not to double over with laughter. Every eye on the bridge turned to stare as their commanding officer broke down in hysterics, before several long seconds passed and he managed to stand up straight suddenly, regaining full control of his emotions.

"Apologies, human. I did not wish to show such obvious delight in your refusal to stand down. Truth be told, I'd prefer it if you fought back. The rage you are about to feel, the hatred, the sadness, the loss of everyone you care for... it will never compare to what you have taken from my kind. Still, it is a start. After we crush your homeworld with Refuge's power, we will eradicate all life from the second world you have colonized, and then we will erase every last strand of your kind from existence, one by one." Nufaris bobbed a finger up and down dramatically as he spoke to emphasize his last few words.

He paused slightly, as he turned to stare at another viewscreen showing Refuge in all of its glory. "It has been so long since I was overcome by emotion. I couldn't even weep for the loss of my people... yet now I will never be happier than I feel at this exact moment. It is a hollow victory, I must admit. I should like to cherish the ecstasy a bit longer."

He made a slight hand motion and the communication was cut off. "Begin the charging sequence."

* * *

Amelia stared at the glowing orb in the room with a perplexed look on her face. "It's... beautiful. What is it?"

"I'm not sure, honestly. Harold is who I was speaking to on the bridge, and he's been inside the orb for as long as I've owned it. At least... since I came back in time."

Harold's face appeared in both of our minds almost simultaneously. Amelia jerked back and she made a cute little 'eek' sound when he startled her. I tried not to laugh, but I failed.

"It took ya decades and ya finally bring her here now? What is up with ya, kid? I don't get it."

Harold seems annoyed, but I see gears immediately start to turn in Amelia's head. "He's been here in this orb for decades and you never told me?"

I scratch the back of my head. "Yeah, about that... I had a good reason."

She doesn't even get mad. "Something to do with the future, I'm sure."

"Yep."

Two minutes later, I finish my explanation and she seems reluctant.

"So I carried the dark orb around and spoke to it?"

"Yes. Just like you do with Leviathan now, except I don't recall Leviathan was ever inside of you in the future. In fact, you and the orb had almost exactly the same relationship as you do with Leviathan now."

"So... you're saying..." She sticks her hands on her hips and stares up in the ceiling as she puts two and two together. "Somehow Leviathan goes from inside me to inside an or- yes, I know, not exactly an upgrade." Her thoughts are interrupted as she speaks to herself again, meaning there's probably some internal dialogue with Leviathan going on.

"The orb that I was using, my friend... his name was Hoarhiim. The black one was named Blaarjiim. When I killed you, I believe Blaarjiim was destroyed as well, and Hoarhiim went inert, which probably-"

She interrupts me. "Hold on, Blaarjiim and Hoarhiim? Are you being serious right now?"

"Err, yes."

She stares down at the floor for a moment as she has another internal dialogue with Leviathan. "He just told me those aren't names, they're titles. Titles from a long dead language, one the dragons used to communicate with each other, millions of years ago."

"Seriously? I never bothered to ask."

"Yes. Blaarjiim means the Bringer of Pain, while Hoarhiim means the Holder of Bliss."

"Oh. That's... appropriate." A thought occurs to me. "Too appropriate."

"I thought so too, kid." Harold seems almost glum now. "Somehow, that dragon must be the one inside that evil orb. He even has a dragon name."

"Title." Amelia corrects the geezer politely but doesn't say anything else.

"Right. Jason, this has been a good talk, boy, but you do realize there's still a war going on?"

My brain snaps back to attention. "I almost forgot."

"You're an idiot." Amelia punches me playfully as I press my hand to her shoulder and teleport us to the bridge instantly.

"I get that a lot." I wink at her before turning to look at Sensei. "How did it go?"

Only then do I notice the metal planet before me has incredibly bright lines of energy surging all over its surface.

"Not well." Sensei almost whispers the words. "That thing... it's a weapon for sure. It's surrounded by an inverted energy barrier a million times stronger than the one any of their ships has... and it's too big to destroy with any of our other ordinance."

"Should I grab an X-wing?" I try to force a smile, but nobody's laughing. Not even me.

Nobody has time to respond as the energy coalesces into a single point just above the equator of the planet. An instant later, it fires.

I've only seen a light that bright once in my life.

* * *

Nufaris stood still, like a rock bearing the weight of a colossal wave as the surf pounds on a beach.

A weapon to rival no other.

"Halfway charged, Executor."

His communications officer spoke up, but Nufaris didn't deign to respond.

It would barely take a minute to charge the anti-gravity accelerator. It had already been thirty seconds.

How many voluntarily gave up their lives to redesign our new home? They were brave, truly honorable Volgrim. They knew billions would have to be purged to make room for the proposed designs, yet they never hesitated. We were fueled by our grief, our anger, our rage. For a species concerned with never letting their emotions get the best of them, we all tacitly agreed to put aside the old ways... at least until we had succeeded in accomplishing our revenge.

"Seventy percent, Executor."

The designs we were given were remarkable. Even considering the source, we knew they couldn't be passed up. Using negative energy to power a weapon that could reduce worlds to rubble? If it gave us a fraction of the power the humans had displayed when they erased our homeworld from existence, it was worth the sacrifices.

"Eighty five percent, Executor."

The grief.

"Ninety percent, Executor."

Let's see how mighty wordsmithing is against a weapon that turns the power against its wielder. Let's see you prevent this calamity, Jason Hiro.

"The Anti-Gravity Accelerator is charged, Executor. On your command."

You erased our planet from the galaxy in the blink of an eye. We will force a slow impending catastrophe in exchange.

"You may fire when ready."

Part 370a: Titanfall (1 of 2)

A blast of energy brighter than the sun shoots out of Refuge, so bright that I can't bear to look directly at it. Shielding my eyes, I quickly look over at Sensei. "We have to stop it from hitting Earth!"

I quickly realize somehow he's put a hypersuit on and he's looking directly at the blast. "It's not aiming at Earth. We can't stop it now."

" **Wear!** " I summon my Hypersuit on and turn to look back at the blast right as it impacts its actual target.

The Moon.

It hits the Moon and a bright flash of light blasts out of the affected area. Seconds later, Refuge stops firing. The beam continues smashing into the moon as the rear section catches up to the forwards section, but eventually it dissipates and all is still.

Several seconds pass. "What... just happened?" Amelia whispers the question out, almost afraid to speak.

"I think they tried to blow up the Moon. They... failed?" My entire body is rigid as I stare at the viewscreen while it examines what's going on. "Harold! Did they pierce the core? Did they destroy the moonbase settlements? What's going on?!"

No response comes for a few seconds, but finally he appears in all of our minds. "Ah... I'm not sure what they did, kid. The Moon's just fine. In fact, they didn't do a lick o' damage where that beam hit."

"What? That's ridiculous! We all saw the explosion!" Sensei's expression is incredulous as his visor opens up fully. "I've never seen an attack of that size cause no damage! What did they hit the Moon wi-"

Harold interrupts him. "God... damn... they weren't tryin' ta blow up the Moon. Oh Jesus, kid. It's worse. Way worse." The screen changes in front of me as a quick visual graphic appears showing the Moon and Earth. A line curves through the moon in a circular motion at first, but then the line turns until it's pointing from the Moon straight at Earth.

"I don't get it, Harold. What did those fuckers do?! Give it to me straight!"

Harold coughs weakly. "They did somethin' with the Moon's gravity. It ain't orbiting Earth no more. It's... falling into Earth. It's falling towards it now."

Sensei steps forwards as he looks at the graphic. "There's a timer counting down. Two hours, forty-seven minutes, twenty-four seconds. This... this is..."

"The time to impact." Amelia finishes the sentence for him. "They're dropping the Moon on Earth, and we've only got two and a half hours to stop it."

Nobody speaks for a few seconds.

"We'd better get moving." I hiss the words out and turn to Sensei. "Gather the clones. All of them. Every last one. Humanity will have to defend themselves against the Volgrim warships on their own."

* * *

The first Supreme Commander Beatrix sat in her mountain retreat on Mars, gazing up at the flash of light in the sky. "That certainly doesn't look good." She stirred a cube of sugar into her tea and stared at the sanitized white walls and floor of her home, wondering where it all went wrong.

I let a madman take over control of Earth, and it's been going to shit ever since. At least Mars is fairly comfortable, as long as you don't like vegetation.

Her butler walked in the room abruptly. "Madam Rose, there's an urgent visitor here. He's from the head of the Mars Joint Coalition."

"Don't call me that. I hate that name." The portly woman rolled around in her chair slightly. "Why should I care about what the warmongers want? Send him away."

"Madam... I know you can be a bit fussy-"

"I'm NOT fussy! Say that to my face one more time!" She glared at the butler and he took a step back meekly in response.

"-but I believe you should listen to him. Earth is under attack. The Volgrim have returned." He finished his response without missing a beat.

She stared at him for a few moments in annoyance before waving her hand. "Fine, send him in. I bet the men screwed up the balance of power in the galaxy again."

"Indubitably." Her butler walked away in a hurry and a half minute later, a wiry looking young man ran into her room huffing. "Commander Beatrix! You need to get dressed and come with me now! There's no time to explain!" His military outfit indicated his rank couldn't be any higher than a corporal. It seemed odd to Beatrix that they would send such a low ranking soldier to bother her. They must have been short on manpower.

"I'm not a commander anymore. The people took that from me." She barely showed any emotion, despite the fact the young man looked to be on the verge of panic. "You've got a man who can shoot lasers out of his eyes, terraform planets, and clone a million more of himself so that they can do all those things too. I won't be much use up there."

"You don't understand, he just recalled all of his clones from every ship in the military! Something huge is happening and we need a military genius!"

She stirred her tea for a few more moments before taking a sip and setting it down. "Fine, but I'll only help in an advisory capacity. After I'm done, never bother me again. I enjoy my peace and quiet."

The young man grabbed her hand as she started to stand up, pulling her to a stand with surprising strength. "Thank you! Thank you, if only you knew what this meant for us!"

"I'm sure I'll know soon enough."

* * *

If you were to tell me that Earth had hours left to live, I'd be hard pressed to believe you. The Moon didn't look any bigger in the sky and I couldn't perceive it getting any bigger, but that probably wasn't going to last long. The wind around me was a slight breeze, and it was a chilly 20F.

I'd probably notice the cold more if my blood weren't boiling with rage.

"Ranger, contact all major governments on Earth and order them to start the evacuation proceedings." Sensei barks an order at one of the other clones nearby and turns away without waiting for a reaction. "We need to get people off Earth. We should start teleporting them immediately."

"I disagree." A nearby clone chimed in. "If we expend energy teleporting people out, we probably won't have enough energy to stop the Moon."

I quickly glanced over at Sensei, looking for hints for what he thought I should do. "I think he's right. If twenty billion people die, we can eventually repopulate, but if the Earth itself is destroyed, Mars can't possibly handle billions of people. Better to let as many as possible evacuate in the colony ships we prepared a few decades ago. If a billion are saved and we have a better shot at saving the nineteen billion remaining, that's the best alternative."

Sensei doesn't seem to like the idea. "If we rip an opening in space, we can teleport all of the people on Earth there temporarily."

"That'll take too much energy. We'll be too drained to stop the moon and we lose that way. And if that drains our energy and we can't stop the Moon, those people have nothing to return

to."

Sensei chews on his thumb as he mulls it over. "Seven hundred and fifty million. That's how many people our colony ships can hold, since the ones in North America were taken by the demons. We might be able to rescue a billion more under ordinary circumstances, but that's only if we had access to the entire fleet and no Volgrim at our doorsteps. Hell, the colony ships might be blasted to pieces right after exiting the atmosphere." His gaze lowers as he speaks. "Besides, if the Moon hits, it's going to have reverberations throughout the entire solar system. Mars' orbit might be destabilized."

"We'll stabilize it then. Let's not be fatalistic here. We have a few dozen containers filled with energy, plus 40,000 clones here. We've got more than enough energy to save the world if we put our mind to it."

"We don't." Sensei raises his hand to stop me from saying anything else. "I'm already half dry from the battle. I put a lot of energy into the ship shield generators, and I'm a first generation clone. Many of the others here aren't doing any better, and they're probably all way worse off than me. Not to mention we halved the energy of 10,000 clones to make new clones... The energy we have left is much less than you think."

Everyone is silent for a few moments as I and all of my clones in the area glance around uneasily. One nearby raises his hand. "There's... there's always... *reintegration*."

Sensei immediately shoots a look of anger at him. "Don't even suggest such a thing. Original would never be able to live with himself if he did that. We all know it!"

Despite his words, I involuntarily lick my lips. Reintegration, huh... it made Hope insanely powerful for a short time. If I didn't have the power of the three Archangels, I'd have surely lost to him. He must have increased his energy output by a factor of a few hundred.

But... there were only a fraction as many clones back then as there are now. If it boosted his powers by that much, what would it do to me?

What would it do... to me?

I realize Sensei is staring at me with his mouth slightly agape. "You're not seriously considering reintegration, are you?"

"No, no. Just trying to think of alternatives." I immediately lie as I feel guilt cross over my face. Truth be told, I goddamn was. Our options are growing more limited every minute. If I want to save Earth, nothing can be off the table.

"Why not just shove the moon back into orbit?" A different clone nearby asks the question and all of us look around to see what the general consensus is.

"What word would we use? Push? Gravity? Orbit?" Sensei seems interested in the idea.

"The exact word doesn't matter. All that counts is the intent. Push was one we used like a form of telekinesis, but that was before we time traveled, before we knew anything about our power. It came out like a gust of energy from our body, but we could make it more precise."

Sensei shrugs. "Seems as good as any other suggestion. The moon is a quarter the size of Earth. If we were to try to move Earth, it would take more than four times as much energy, but shoving the moon back into orbit would have the least deleterious effects on the solar system anyway."

"The only problem with most of these suggestions is the size of the moon, and... one other thing." I bite my lip hard. "What if we actually succeed in getting the moon back into orbit, but Refuge fires another shot and sends the Moon right back at us? There's no way we'll manage saving Earth a second time."

"We could blow up the moon!" Another clone chimes in and everyone ignores him. I'm not the smartest guy in the world, but even I know that might actually be worse than what we're facing now.

Everyone stiffens as a blast of wind hits us. The planet's ecosystems must have finally noticed the massive sphere of rock and dirt falling towards us.

"We'll worry about that if it happens. Time is of the essence right now." Sensei's voice is hard as steel. "Let's just try to shove the Moon back into orbit. That's as good a place to start as any other."

"Right!" Nearly every clone yells in unison.

But not me. "Wait, I have one other idea. It just came to me. Rather than reintegrating all of the clones, why don't all of you give me your energy, then I'll have the maximum amount to use at once?"

I feel taken aback as everyone around me stares with wide eyes.

"Original... that's the smartest thing you've ever said."

Sensei's words somehow feel more like an insult than a compliment.

"Beats the hell out of reintegration."

"You said it."

* * *

"No!!" Gabriel screamed in rage as the First Emperor of the demons finally plowed his fist through Zeus's head, tearing his brains from within and crushing his skull with his bare hands.

"Zeus! No!"

Satan cackled maniacally as he tossed the body of the King of Gods to the ground without a hint of remorse. "The king has fallen! Let this be a lesson for all who oppose the demons! Our revenge will come when you least expect it!"

The leader of the demons had barely finished speaking when another massive anti-energy explosion lit up in the distance. Gabriel felt his knees shake as the energy of thousands of angels vanished into a void, never to be seen again.

Satan scowled as he looked over at Gabriel. "What a shame! Seems a few of my minions were caught in that blast!"

"You poor child!" Gabriel charged at the leader of the demons with his own holy sword held at the ready, slashing from the left and right as Satan dodged from here to there. A few swipes managed to strike their intended target though, and Satan quickly leaped backwards and winced as he grabbed at his chest.

"Bastard! You'll pay for sullyng my perfect body!"

"I'll pay with holy retribution!" Gabriel whipped his palm up and blasted a colossal beam of energy at Satan, feeling his breath catch in his throat. His Cosmic form had already lost its utility and couldn't be used for a long time. Now he was using his own life energy, though it was quite tremendous.

Satan raised his hand up to his mouth as the blast surged towards him, but he seemed to be too slow. The blast impacted him a moment later, destroying everything in the immediate area where he had just been standing.

Gabriel gawked as he stared at the spot where the smoke was clearing. "Did I get the demon?"

"No." Satan spoke quietly from just a few feet to Gabriel's side and the archangel leaped back in surprise.

"What?! I hit you! Where did you come fr-"

He didn't get to finish his sentence. Satan took a quick hop towards him and made a chopping motion with the side of his hand right at the back of Gabriel's neck, stunning the archangel and making him fall to his knees.

"Look at how your kingdom falls, archangel! I warned you over a thousand years ago that I would return and finish what I started, and I am not one to go back on my word!"

Gabriel jerked back up to his feet and glared at the evil being before him. Both of them were tall, broad shouldered members of their own kind. They saw eye to eye, but Gabriel knew in his

heart... the demon would never be his equal.

"You resort to cowardly tactics like ambushing and using hostages! You will get your comeuppance, that I can assure you!"

Even as he yelled, Gabriel's eyes looked past Satan at all of the angels falling left and right. All around him, friends and loved ones were being cut down with vicious precision and perfect aim. The demons didn't care who they killed or who they lost, so long as the victory was a crushing one.

Satan's eyes followed Gabriel's gaze. He smiled widely. "Do you like the view? You're the last one, archangel. We've killed all of the pureblood angels, and all that are left are the inferior false angels. Your end has finally come."

Satan's smile faded away and he lowered his hands. "I'll give you one chance. Impale yourself on your sword, and I will call off my forces. With you gone, the Resurrection Project will stop working, and the angels will never be a threat to me again. I am not a monster. The pseudo-angels here today have nothing to do with my grievances against the purebloods from millennia ago. Kill yourself, bend the knee, and you may yet spare some of these inferiors."

Gabriel stared resolutely at the demon before him. "Never. I'll never bow to you. I'll fight to the last breath."

Satan raised his hand and wagged a finger at the archangel. "Careful now. I've let you live up to now, but ending you would be trivial. Giving up your life to spare those remaining... it would be the best way to atone for the crimes the angels have committed against human and demon alike. I am not wholly unmerciful, and unlike the filthy angels, I always keep my word."

Gabriel felt his resolve weaken. *Every second I debate, more of the false angels are slain. I can't just let them all die. I can't just give up... but... I can't just fight for my own selfish reasons... at this rate, we'll lose no matter what...*

The archangel lifted his head to stare at the empty sky above. *If only I could contact Jason Hiro... if only... this might have ended differently.*

Gabriel swallowed as blood trickled down his throat. "I... I..."

Satan smiled. "Go ahead. I'm waiting."

* * *

The energy inside of me is greater than I've ever felt in my life. It swirls and spins like a maelstrom of rage. I've never felt power like this... in this timeline.

Yes, once before, I felt this way. When I had the energy of the Archangels, I possessed more power than I do now. Still, this energy is different. It's not an alien energy given to me by a

foreign entity, but energy taken from myself, my other selves. My clones gave me all of their energy willingly, except that which they needed to teleport themselves away. It's just Sensei and I now, standing on Earth, staring up at a moon that is growing imperceptibly larger every minute.

"Okay... here I go..." I grit my teeth as I stare up at the Moon above me. I raise my hands to the sky and dig my boots into the ground.

" **REVERSE!!** "

I yell at the top of my lungs and feel a decent portion of energy leave my body. I pant for a few moments and stare at the Moon.

"Did it work?" Sensei squints as he looks up. "Try again."

"Alright. Here I go again..." I take a deep breath and bellow again. " **REVER-** " Immediately, a voice screams in my hypersuit's ear speaker.

"STOP! Dumbass! Whatever yer doin', stop!" Harold's wise voice bellows back and me and catches me off guard, making me fall on my ass.

"What's wrong, Harold? What's going on?"

Harold is at the edge of sanity. "I don't know what ya' just did, but ya' just made it go faster! It's really falling towards Earth now! You just went from two 'n a half hours ta' an hour 'n a half! Stop right now!"

His words make daggers of ice shoot down my spine. I jerk my head towards Sensei. "You heard the man, right?"

"Damn right I did. Did you visualize it correctly? You're supposed to reverse it from Earth, not reverse it towards Earth."

"I know! That's what I did. I don't know what went wrong."

Sensei is agitated now, and the wind around us has started to pick up with intensity. Snow and sleet is starting to fall, it's getting hard to see. "Try a different word! Use push, that might work."

"All right." I send a mental message to Harold. "Monitor the Moon! Let me know if anything changes!"

Gathering my breath, I scream again. " **PUSH!** "

This time, I feel something. It's as if I shoved away from an impenetrable wall. The energy from my wordsmithing is reflected right back at me, and a colossal wave of power smashes into

me, beating me into the ground in a millisecond with force that would have liquefied my body if not for the fact I was wearing my hypersuit.

I can barely think as waves of nausea pass over me. "Haah, gnuh..."

My mouth isn't working properly. I feel like I was hit by a freight train. Only when my head lolls to the side do I see Sensei pulling himself up to his feet. The blast wave must have hit him too.

"Original... kahaha... you fucking moron... I get it now..." He quickly heals himself with wordsmithing, then heals me as well. Harold chimes in before Sensei can explain. "Now it's moving even faster! You got less than an hour!"

Sensei and I both stare into the sky in disbelief. "I can't believe it. We don't have the power to stop it."

He whacks me in the arm. "We do! Just use your head! There's one more thing we can do!"

"What? Tell me!"

He shakes his head quickly. "Not reintegration. I know you were thinking that. Instead, let's create a support to physically stop the moon."

My quizzical expression makes him realize who he's talking to. "A glove. A hand. Let's create a massive hand in outer space and physically halt it."

I stare at him for several seconds, before he looks away. "Fuck it! I don't know! It was just a suggestion! I just..."

Both of us lower our heads as despair fills our minds. "Sensei... we can't save the Earth. I'm going to give you all the energy I have now. Get as many humans teleported off the planet and into colony ships as you can. We should have done this in the first place."

"What about you?" He lifts his head up and our eyes lock. "What are you planning?"

"I made a mistake. Refuge didn't just hit the moon with a beam that shoved it towards Earth... it must have charged the moon with negative energy or something. The more I hit it with wordsmithing, the faster it's going to travel."

"What are you saying then? How can you possibly stop it?"

"I can't. What I can do is use the remaining energy in my storage containers... and I'll try to move the Earth backwards, maybe to a different direction so the Moon misses... but gravity doesn't work that way. I can at least try to prolong the inevitable. It'll be up to you to save as many humans as you can... and to stop the Volgrim from attacking Mars."

I grab Sensei's shoulders and stare him in the eye. "If push comes to shove, I don't care what it takes... reintegrate the clones. You cannot let the Volgrim have this. You cannot let them win."

He pulls away from my grip and stares at me with a look of revulsion. "I... couldn't. Never."

"Don't give me that shit. I'd willingly die if it meant saving the galaxy from evil, as would you and all of my clones. We're not heroes other than in title, but humanity looks up to us as if we are. Don't you squander the sacrifices so many have made to get us to where we are now. Don't you *dare* shit on their hopes and dreams just to pretend to be moral and upright. You and I both know we're beyond redemption now."

Sensei seems to have a look of betrayal pass over his face, but finally he shakes his head. "Fine. If I absolutely must... I will. I'll do it. Don't you die on me. It better be the last resort."

"It will be. Now go! People are dying every second you waste!"

Sensei's eyes tear up and he looks away as his visor closes. Without another word, he teleports away.

Turning back, I stare up at the orb in the sky above. Now I see it... it's definitely getting bigger. The winds are howling at ungodly speeds, with only the power of the hypersuit keeping me upright.

"Harold. I'm going to try to move Earth. Tell me if I'm wasting my time or if this has any effect at all."

"You got it, kid."

Harold sounds uneasy, but I wish that was all I felt. I've never been as terrified in my life as I am right now.

After pulling four containers of energy from my storage, I kneel down and slap my gloved hands to the ground. " **MOVE!!** "

Part 371a: Titanfall (2 of 2)

It's so dark now. My suit has to activate night-vision mode just to see around me. The entire sky is black, with a small patch of grey to the east from a trickle of sunlight.

My energy is gone now. The last container is in my hands, and I just absorbed it.

Minutes. That's all we've got left. I'll have to evacuate from this place before it hits. Should I? Do I deserve to?

"Harold. How many colony ships managed to escape?" I speak calmly to the old-timer in my mind, though out loud I yell at the top of my lungs. " **MOVE!!** "

"All of 'em, kid. Last ship blasted off five minutes ago. Now git out of there! There's nothing more ya can do!"

He's a bad liar. "They're all destroyed, aren't they?"

Harold's face turns away slightly in my mind's eye. "They never had a chance. The Volgrim shot 'em before they got off the ground. Knew right where they were located."

"Ha... haha... a traitor, then. Maybe someone with good intel... I can't, though. I can't just let them all die..."

The wind screams all around me. I used 'root' to plant myself in the ground, but if I hadn't, the several hundred mile an hour wind would have dashed me against a mountain long ago. Even with my suit filtering out the sounds from outside, some of it trickles inside. It's as if an unending sea of people are fleeing for their lives from an unseen threat.

"Don't be a hero, son. Ya can't save the planet. Ya did the best ya could."

"No. I didn't. The other clones were right. I should have teleported as many people off the planet as I had the power to do so. They're all dead because of me."

By now, I'm beginning to feel insanely heavy. The wind is pounding me with such ferocity that I feel like gravity has increased tenfold.

"And if ya saved 'em, they'd have no place to call home! What would you do, make another Earth?!"

"Maybe." I stare numbly at the sky before closing my eyes. "I should finally pay for my failures. It's time. Sensei is smarter than me... he's more fit to lead."

Harold goes quiet for a moment. "Now listen here, ya son of a bitch. We don't know what'd happen if ya die. Yer clones might disappear. Even if they didn't, that's no way for a friend o'

mine to talk. Do you hear me, soldier?!"

He's going full drill sergeant mode. I can hear it in his voice.

"All I ever do is screw up, and yet until today the universe kept handing me victories. Today the universe gets even."

"You got one minute to get out of there, son! Don't you do this to me!"

My head's feeling light. Even with the suit fully closed up, I feel as if there's a lack of air.

"I'm just... tired. I can't save the Earth, I can't save anyone. This is for the best."

Before Harold can reply, I cut the mental connection and tilt backwards, causing the wind to smash me into the ground on my back.

That's all right... I'm tired anyway. Tired of running the show, tired of people's expectations of me, tired of losing all the people I know. I'm ready for something else.

And who knows? Maybe the Hypersuit will save me from being crushed. Let's test that theory out.

My eyes close and I feel a deep sleep come over me.

I'll let fate decide my future.

* * *

The power was out, and Jorge sat on the couch in his living room staring out the shattered window as hurricane force winds blew inside. He could barely even feel the icy cold in his delirium, but still he clutched a glass half-full of vodka and plenty of other nasty items blown in from outside.

The revolver from earlier was still clutched in his left hand, but his arm flopped at his side uselessly.

I can't feel anything anymore. I'm so numb now.

The faint sound of breaking glass and concrete grinding on more concrete was audible from the kitchen, but he ignored it.

Not much longer now.

In his mind's eye, he saw how he once had everything a man could desire. A beautiful wife, a lovely daughter, a house, and an illustrious career. Respect from his colleagues and the ability to live in relative freedom however he wanted.

And it was all useless in the end. We come in this world alone, and leave it alone. I'm more than just alone, though. I'm completely isolated.

A shard of glass zipped past his head, missing him by a millimeter. He didn't even flinch.

I always wondered to myself if humanity was evil or not. This is retribution for all the evil we've done. We destroyed their planet, so they're going to destroy us.

The rear side of the house finally gave way and collapsed, tearing from the ground and lifting up slightly into the air as the maelstrom ripped it from the earth.

We deserve this. I deserve this.

Finally, Jorge let go of the gun and his fingers glided up towards his chest pocket. A moment later, he pulled out a familiar picture, clenching it tightly so the wind wouldn't take it.

I'm an atheist. I never prayed to any god in my life. My wife and daughter though... they were better than me. They will be in Heaven. All I ask is that the gods take my prayers... let them be happy. Let them be safe. If I deserve to be saved... let it be so.

He chuckled even as the wind swirling around the room took the breath from his throat.

Even sinners deserve a second chance... right?

A moment later, a wooden beam directly above him split in half and fell towards the man on the couch.

He wouldn't have screamed, even if he had the energy to do so.

* * *

"So that's it, huh? Just gonna give up?"

A voice from my right side speaks dryly and I recognize it immediately. "It's impossible, Arthur. Earth is gone. I failed."

"What a positive thinker." Arthur waves his hand at the beautiful green meadow all around us. "I created this place with my mind as a way to escape my troubles. I fled the world of the living because I'd given up hope for my redemption."

"Yeah... so what are you implying?"

"I'm saying you're a coward. I'm saying you disappoint me." Arthur rubs the underside of his nose with a finger as he glares at me. "You have a power that effectively makes you a god above actual gods. You have the ability to reshape reality as we know it. What gives you the right to give up under such a weak catastrophe?"

"My power wasn't enough. I couldn't even stop the moon. What would you do in my place?"

Arthur rolls his eyes. "I don't know. All I know is that surviving to fight another day in order to save as many as possible is the best solution."

"You locked yourself inside of a sword."

For once, I can't help but notice he looks flustered. "Y-yeah, I did... but you're still a dumbass."

"I'm just following the example you set, Arthur. If I'm a dumbass, what does that make you?"

He opens his mouth to respond, but then closes it for a few moments before actually responding. "Shut up. Get out of here. Save your own skin."

"I don't see why I should bother."

"It's not a request. It's an order. There's someone waiting for you to return. Don't you dare make her cry."

I don't even get a chance to reply. Arthur fades away and a whiteness surrounds me.

A moment later I wake up and... Amelia is hovering above me, yelling at my face. Her words are muted at first, as if an explosion sounded off nearby and deafened me, but soon I realize what she's saying.

"Wake up! Get up!"

I blink my eyes quickly and pull myself into a sitting position. Jesus, I nearly let myself give up that easily. Arthur was right, I can't just let myself die! I can't just...

...Uh...

My expression flattens as surprise floods me. To my left, standing a few feet away, is Arthur.

"Yo. You're up." He stands with Excalibur held in one hand, and his kingly attire worn in all of its splendor.

It suddenly occurs to me that it's very quiet all around us. Glancing up, my heart skips a beat as I realize the moon seems even closer than it was before I passed out.

"We're going to die! We have to go!" Amelia pulls me up but even as I stand and tower over her, I keep looking up.

"Why hasn't the moon hit yet?"

"I'm moving the Earth backwards, like you were doing." Arthur smiles pleasantly, as if he hasn't a care in the world. "And before you ask, you're standing inside my Crusader Aura. It usually protects me from most blows, but I extended it to cover all three of us."

I find myself gawking at him for a few seconds. "You're pulling the Earth away? Can you save it?!"

"Not a chance. Even if I'd started when the Moon was first launched, it'd eventually hit. Earth is doomed."

I find myself marveling at how we're having a normal conversation even as impending death is approaching us.

"We need to go. Let's have the talkies when we get back on the Mothership." Amelia pulls at my hand and I nod along slowly, still staring at Arthur in shock.

"You materialized yourself?"

"Yup. I realized the best way to atone would be to make sure Earth's doom didn't also kill our best hero." He smiles at me, then wags his finger. "The girl is right though. We need to go. You two teleport back to the ship, and I'll follow after I release my hold on Earth."

"You're not going to do anything stupid, are you?"

Arthur's smile seems to fade slightly, but maybe it's just my imagination. "No... no of course not. Just go on ahead."

"You're lying... aren't you?" Disbelief floods my mind. He can't be serious. He just lectured me about foolhardy gestures of suicide, but he's going to stay behind?!

"Perhaps." His smile vanishes completely and he takes a few steps towards me. "If you won't go, I'll make you go."

My jaw drops. "You have to come with us, you have to-" He jerks his hand forwards suddenly and taps my chest with one finger. A moment later, Amelia and I both appear on the bridge of the Mothership.

"-survive!" I finish my sentence and stumble forwards in surprise. The sudden appearance on the ship caught me off guard.

Amelia stares at me as I turn to her. "Who is that guy anyway?"

* * *

Arthur stared up at the sky. Somewhere, in a place he couldn't see, his pupil had landed safely aboard his flying space vessel.

It was good knowing you, Jason Hiro.

Earth's doom was seconds away now. The moon's color would change the moment it hit the atmosphere. Once it got that far, it would be too late. It wouldn't take a second longer to hit the ground.

I doubt even you, with all of your power, could change the will of the Creator. That's the thing about time, it's like a river. Your actions are rocks, but time merely flows around you. It simply diverts on its course and continues towards its original goal.

Arthur raised Excalibur into the air, and aimed the point of it directly at the moon.

Perhaps, if you had more power, you could change things. Maybe if you had more energy, it would not be a stone you throw into the water, but a boulder. If you had such power, things might have turned out differently.

Energy began building up at Arthur's feet as he released his hold on the Earth.

You alone have the power to see the flow of time. Someday, if you live long enough, you might figure out how to change the will of the universe. Today is not that day.

The energy surged from Arthur's feet up through his body and into his upraised hand.

They called me a hero. In truth, I was a monster. A killer. All I've ever done with my life is take the lives of others.

Excalibur began to glow as Arthur knelt down to put every last drop of his colossal energy reserves into the sword.

But not you. You can make a difference. You can change things. I will always just be a killer.

The sword vibrated fiercely as energy screamed inside of it.

In the end, that's all I need to do. Stay true to myself. Be a killer.

"I'm coming, Elizabeth. Sorry I kept you waiting."

Arthur reached up with his free hand and wiped away a single tear. He had no reason to be sad. Soon, they would be together again.

In the blink of an eye, the blade fired. The energy shockwave wiped out all life within a hundred miles instantly.

Arthur, the Knight of Camelot, had perished.

Part 372a: Sacrifice

"Time to impact?" Nufaris directed the question to one of his scanning officers. The Executor lightly shifted a familiar memory manipulator from one hand to another, though he always took care to be gentle with it. It was, of course, the key to leading the Volgrim to a better future.

"A minute to impact, though for some reason the planet appears to be moving away from the moon. Our previous predictions were off by several minutes." The scanning officer stared intently at the screen before him, taking careful note of the projections that were coming in real time waves.

"Contact Archjusticar Thrandis." Nufaris sent his order over towards the communications officer, and she complied quickly.

It took only a few seconds for the Archjusticar to appear onscreen. "Executor Nufaris, are we to depart now?"

"No. Stay until the Moon impacts the Earth. Humans can be tricky. If they manage a last second reversal, we need to hit the Moon again to ensure impact. Once the impact is confirmed, activate the sub-light drives and head to the fourth planet. They will face our wrath next."

Thrandis held up three fingers and crossed his thumb over, as was the tradition for respect among high ranking Volgrim. "Understood. Executor, have you any other orders? Our secondary fleet is still waiting to launch from aboard Refuge. We could assist in the battle to thin the herd. The humans may come up with a counter for Refuge once we assault their fourth planet."

Nufaris reached up and scratched his chin. "Earth's moon is massive, it will easily be able to destroy the entire planet. Even with a constant rapid acceleration of both of the fourth planet's moons, they are unlikely to devastate the entire planet. At best, we can target the major population centers, then follow up with an orbital bombardment."

The Executor hesitated, as uncertainty clouded his thoughts. "With that in mind, perhaps keeping the secondary fleet in reserve would be best, saving their weapons for a last minute surprise."

Thrandis crossed his massive arms together across the front of his cream-colored uniform. "Understood, Executor. Once impact has been confirmed, we will move quickly to assault the fourth planet. I contemplate, and I comprehend."

The Archjusticar started to motion to his nearby crewman to cut the connection, but someone aboard the Dolfraxis yelped in alarm. "Executor! I'm detecting a massive energy reading on Earth's surface!"

Nufaris flinched at the news. "Filthy humans, I knew they'd have one last trick. What is it? What's causing the reading?"

He felt slightly worried, but even he knew there couldn't possibly be a way for the humans to save their planet now. Wordsmithing had real, tangible limitations, according to his source.

"It's- it's still charging! Ten seconds to impact from Earth's moon!"

Nufaris's breathing sharpened as the viewscreen changed to show the Moon racing towards certain destruction of the planet.

"Executor! What is going on?" Refuge's commander spoke, but his face wasn't visible on the screen.

"We're working on it. I'll tell you when we-"

"It's firing!" The scanning officer yelled at the top of his lungs. A moment later, five seconds before the moon struck, a colossal explosion erupted from its dark side, and a thin but impossibly fast beam of light shot through the opening.

"Type 3 energy confirmed! It must be from Earth's Supreme Commander!"

Instantly, Nufaris realized the trajectory calculations weren't wrong. "Thrandis! Raise shields! Maximum power! It's going to hit Refuge!"

A moment later, the Moon smashed into Earth.

* * *

" **Teleport! Return!** " I yell the words, but nothing happens. "He's blocking me out! I can't return to where he is!"

Amelia pulls me by my arm and shakes me roughly. "Stop, Jason! You can't go back there! He told me he wouldn't allow it!"

Her words shake me to my core. "You... knew about this?"

"Of course. He teleported me down there and told me only I could prevent you from going insane! Stop acting so reckless!" She slaps my chest, as if trying to snap me out of a hallucination. "He has a plan to save the Earth... he told me he did!"

So she says... but... that couldn't be true. He told me himself...

I quickly put my hand on Amelia's shoulder. " **Teleport.** "

We arrive at the Mothership's bridge and are greeted by a familiar face. "Original, you made it!" Sensei breathes a sigh of relief. "I was worried you were going to do something really stupid."

"I almost didn't. Luckily, Arthur stopped me." I pull my hand away from Amelia's shoulder and quickly walk over to the scanning console. "Harold, tell me what's going on down there."

"Arthur?" Sensei seems perplexed and then I remember I never told him about Arthur. Hell, I never told *anyone* about him.

"An old friend." I keep the answer short, as the countdown timer indicates there's less than a half-minute to impact.

"Thank god, yer back, kid!" Harold's elderly voice speaks directly into my mind, and, despite myself, I can't help but smile. "Yer friend down there, he's doing some crazy stuff! Seems like he's charging up his energy!"

"What? His energy? That doesn't make sense."

And it doesn't. He's often bragged about his ridiculous control over energy, but even if that's true, what's he going to do, blast the moon into a trillion pieces? That will just make a trillion asteroids rain down on Earth and kill everything. It's the same as if the Moon hit Earth intact, and possibly even worse.

Not to mention the energy will probably just be absorbed by the moon and make the impact even faster. What is he thinking?!

"I dunno, kid, but the energy readings are off the charts! It's like he's creatin' a new star on the surface or somethin'."

"Ten seconds to impact." Amelia yells the numbers out, but we all have our eyes locked to the countdown timer anyway.

"What the hell is a pointless sacrifice going to achieve?! He can't save-" I pause midsentence, as something occurs to me. "Harold, what trajectory is Refuge located at?"

The old man brings the numbers up almost at the same time I ask the question, bless his soul.

"He's... not trying to save Earth! He's trying to save Mars!"

A moment later, the dark side of the moon explodes as a blast of energy surges forwards at nearly the speed of light. Two more seconds pass and I realize my suspicions were correct. The Moon smashes into Earth, and a titanic shockwave erupts through space, shoving even our ship off-course. We're over a hundred thousand miles from Earth, and it only takes seconds for us to feel the aftereffects of the impact.

At the same time, the blast of energy streaks through space, careening towards its target at twice the distance from Earth from which the Moon started.

And then it hits.

Nothing happens.

All of us stare breathlessly as the light from the blast fizzles out, the viewscreen indicating it impacted an invisible wall of energy. Refuge's force field... it was simply too strong.

His sacrifice was in vain.

* * *

Nufaris finally let out a breath he had been holding. The unbelievably high density energy beam had been nullified by their inverse polarity field.

Refuge was safe.

"That was far too close for my liking." Nufaris smiled politely as the screen shifted back to Archjusticar Thrandis.

"I agree. We should begin immediate transfer to the fourth planet." Thrandis adjusted the collar on his uniform. "On your orders, Executor."

"As you will. I'm giving you full command of the strike force for the time being. Show humanity the might of the Volgrim."

"I contemplate, and I comprehend." The Archjusticar made a quick gesture and his viewscreen cut off. The Dolfraxis now turned its highly advanced scanning array towards the ravaged planet. Already, several scanners had been knocked offline due to massive electromagnetic interference from the impact, and their ship would face great danger once millions of tons of debris were jettisoned into space and had a large chance of impacting them.

"Impact confirmed. Yotta-joules of energy released from impact. Liquefaction of the planet's crust and mantle is spreading all over the surface. Estimated chance of even a single life-form's survival... 0%."

"Let's not be so pessimistic, officer. I'm sure there will be some bacteria that survive, at least for a while." Nufaris stared ahead blankly as his deadpan humor caused the entire bridge to chuckle for a moment. "Enough of that. We have a war to win. Hail the Supreme Commander's ship. Let's see what he has to say now."

If he's still alive.

Nufaris kept that thought to himself. Who else but the main Jason Hiro would have that much power left over to completely shoot through the inverse polarity field that had surrounded

the Moon?"

The viewscreen shifted once again as two of Jason Hiro's clones appeared on the screen.

"My apologies, but I gave you a chance for complete surrender. The destruction of your planet, and your Supreme Commander, is on your hands."

"I'm still alive." One of the clones spoke up, and Nufaris shifted his feet slightly.

Ah, perhaps he didn't die.

"A shame. I assumed that was your heroic last stand. It would seem you're too foolish to die with dignity, as Founder Unarin did when you destroyed his beloved homeworld." Nufaris forced a tight smile, but the edges of his eyes twitched.

"One of my best friends died on Earth today. He died trying to save our kind from you. You started this war, but I'll make sure we end it."

Jason was clearly enraged, but Nufaris' smile faded.

"We started the war? I think not. It was your kind who started this. Your barbarism and intent to destroy us was projected from the very first time we met. Once we've exterminated your filth from the galaxy, we'll be sure to hold a hundred year celebration in memory of your destruction."

Jason's teeth ground together noticeably. "It doesn't matter who started the war. All that matters is who wins. You've got the upper hand now, but I hold the power of a god. Unless you can manage to kill myself and all of my clones, you'll never be able to sleep soundly at night. You'll always know we're out there, just waiting for the opportune moment to strike."

Nufaris kept his expression neutral as he smoothed his shirt down. "Why wait? Teleport over here now and strike me down."

The human didn't respond.

"That's what I thought. You might be a god, but even a god has a crippling weakness. Inverse polaric energy would kill you if you came into contact with it. Perhaps not instantly, but quickly enough. We know your weakness."

Jason Hiro seemed to be struggling to find words to respond with.

Excellent. His indecision proves I'm right. He is terrified of me. He doesn't know how to handle a situation his wordsmithing can't solve.

Nufaris opened his mouth to gloat again, but the viewscreen cut off suddenly and his communication officer whirled around in his seat. "I beg forgiveness, Executor! I cut the feed! Refuge is hailing on emergency channels! Code Theta Prime!"

The highest leader of the Volgrim stiffened. "Onscreen."

Immediately, he was greeted by chaos. Aboard Refuge, all of the crewman were running around the bridge in a frenzy, and it took two seconds for Thrandis to whip his head around and realize the screen was on.

"Executor! It's the apocalypse! The power compensators are overloaded! Our mass stabilizers are overburdened! The polaric field is suffering a critical collapse! Even the warp core is about to breach!"

"What?!" Nufaris reeled and took a step back. "What happened?! Was the station hit by debris from the impact?!"

"No! Executor, we need to abandon ship! That blast of energy that hit us overloaded all of our failsafes! Refuge is-"

The screen cut off and everyone aboard the Dolfraxis stared at the now blank viewscreen in bewilderment, nobody daring to even breathe.

The scanning officer slowly reached over and pressed a button and the viewscreen displayed the pride of the Volgrim army, the battle station Refuge. Explosions covered the surface as every system at once seemed to be erupting with a fiery rage. Ten seconds later, the station's outer hull was replaced with an explosion the likes of which rivaled that of the moon striking the Earth. The station erupted outwards in every direction, all of its pieces being blown to the far corners of the Terran system.

In the vacuum of space, its total destruction made no noise, but the light illuminated the entire room with a white-hot fury.

Not long after, Nufaris stared ahead blankly at the black void of space.

Refuge was gone.

The Executor, highest among all Volgrim, slumped to his knees.

"R... Retreat. Retreat."

The words were barely a whisper.

* * *

Nobody said anything for several seconds. Finally, I broke the silence.

"He... did it. I don't know how... but he did it."

Amelia's lips pursed as she tried to take in the scene before her. "What? What did he do?"

"That blast of light we saw... he must have done something to make their battle station self destruct. I wouldn't believe it unless I saw it myself." I send a quick mental message to Harold

and he pulls us away from Earth at high speeds. The planet is a molten hellhole now, and there's no saving it... plus every second we stay close to it is another second a massive chunk of debris might smash us to bits.

The Dolfraxis vanishes as it jumps to warp speed. All over the system, our scanners indicate that other Volgrim ships are leaving in a hurry.

"You did it... Arthur. You did it." I mumble to myself as I walk over and flop into the captain's chair. A goddamn miracle saved us.

I suppose 'saved' is not the right word to use. Earth is gone. The Moon is gone. All we have left is the Mars base. If the Volgrim come up with another planet busting scheme, we lose completely.

"We need to expand." Sensei speaks up, surprising me. He seems to be thinking the same thing I am. "This is no time for us to mope around. The Volgrim are running scared, but once they regroup, they will likely attack again. If they hit Mars, it's all over for us."

Amelia walks over and sits on my lap, leaning back to let her hair fall all over me. "There's still Revival."

Ah, I'd almost forgotten about that. "Right. Hawkeye will be there eventually. I think there's another year or two, and once he sets up a beacon, we can move much of humanity there after terraforming. We can... uh..." I shoot a glance over at Sensei. "You recalled all the clones, right? I hope you didn't recall Hawkeye."

"I didn't. I explicitly left him out of the communication, because if something happened and all of us fell, he could still do something to retain the balance of power. He's a second generation clone, after all. He's only a quarter as powerful as you, and half as powerful as me, but it's better than having none of us around."

"I wonder about that."

The words seem to flee my lips before I think that maybe I shouldn't utter them.

"What do you mean by that?" Sensei shoots me a derisive glance, and I look away from his gaze.

"Nothing. Not much, anyway. I mean... look at this. In the end, we caused the future to happen. We're the cause of Earth's destruction. We pissed off the Volgrim by destroying their homeworld, and they got revenge by destroying ours."

Amelia tilts her head back to look up at me while she lays against my chest. "I don't think so. I think it would have happened no matter what."

I rest my chin on her forehead and wrap my arms around her. "Maybe. We may never know."

A moment later, I feel an odd sensation in my mind, as if someone is trying to contact me telepathically, but the signal is too weak.

I ponder it for a few moments, then realize that since I have wordsmithing, there's an easy fix.

" **Boost.** "

Amelia and Sensei both glance at me and give looks of curiosity, but I ignore them.

Instead, I focus on the faint voice that speaks to me. Eventually, I perceive a word.

Jason...

I send my own mental response.

Yes, this is me. Who is this?

Several long moments pass and Amelia pulls away from me to stand up and stare. Both she and Sensei seem to realize there's something going on, but they aren't sure what.

You finally responded. The voice is female, and filled with a deep sadness that I'd normally find hard to put into words, had billions of souls not just been lost today.

Who is this?

I shoot the mental question out and wait, before the voice responds again, this time, with more strength.

I'm glad you heard me. It's me... Uzziel. We lost the battle.

My heart suddenly pounds in my chest. Battle?! What battle?! What is she talking about?

Uzziel! Where are you? What's going on?

She's slow to again respond, and I quickly realize why. She's dying.

All the angels are gone. Please... save me...

I don't hesitate. " **Teleport.** "

* * *

Satan paced back and forth, as steam seemed to come out of his ears. The new labyrinth wasn't quite done, but he supposed it was good enough for an emergency evacuation.

"That son of a slime. Filthy alien. He betrayed me. He betrayed me!" Satan jerked his hand forwards and flung a table nearby through the air, its mottled frame smashing against a wall and dumping assorted items all over the floor.

The demons nearby were packed in tight, but everyone winced at his outburst.

"I warned you not to trust him, love." Belial glided over to him and rubbed his shoulders tenderly. "The Volgrim of today are not the Volgrim we first met. Their leader is no Unarin."

"I know that now! Confound him... he betrayed me. He said he would bombard the human side of Earth and we could take over the planet once they were gone. We had a deal!"

"I suppose he doesn't understand that a deal with the Devil can't be broken." The human Marie paced around nearby, though her angelic counterpart was off somewhere doing experiments and other things. "Maybe he's an atheist."

"Funny." Satan growled at her in a way that clearly indicated he did *not* find it the slightest bit amusing. "He's lucky I had the new Labyrinth prepared. If I hadn't, all of demonkind would have perished."

"He probably hoped for that." Marie chomped into an apple loudly, her lips smacked as she rolled the sweet, crunchy chunk from one side of her mouth to the other. "Honestly, after today, I don't think he can be called a team player. He probably killed Unarin."

Satan rolled his eyes as he sat down at a chair and put his face in his hands. "Doubtful. Unarin was not like the other Volgrim. He had a special power, some connection to spiritual energy. That's how he managed to escape Heaven after we left him for dead."

"Right. You betrayed him, so now you're shocked his successor would betray you." Marie took another massive bite of her apple. "Mmm, this is juicier than I remember. I'm going to miss home-grown fruit."

"Shut up. I'm going to miss a lot more than that." Satan, the all powerful leader of the demons, sulked to himself and fumed. "I'll make the bastard pay. I swear it."

Belial stopped rubbing his shoulders, walked around, and knelt down in front of him. "Come on, love. Surely you aren't going to target another race for revenge? You finally took out the entirety of angelkind! I was hoping we could finally spend some time together!"

Satan forced a smile through for his beautiful concubine. "The Volgrim are number two on my revenge list. Jason Hiro is in first place."

Marie tilted her head slightly as she polished off the apple and tossed it to the side. "I know you and him have a rivalry, but what did he do to deserve your hate?"

"Plenty. But... not protecting the Earth from the Volgrim... it's unacceptable. If I had his power, I wouldn't be so weak."

"We gave the Volgrim the technology for inverse energy. I made it myself. You know why he couldn't protect Earth." Marie sat back against the desk and shrugged at him. "You shouldn't be

mad at him for being unable to protect Earth. The Volgrim were the ones to attack Earth. They violated the deal."

Satan stared stonily at her for a moment before turning slightly to stare at the wall. "You say that, but I'm still mad. I'm pissed. He's too weak... he could have done something."

"Like what?"

"I don't know!...Something."

Satan stood up and patted Belial on the head before storming to the door. "I'm going for a walk. Don't follow me."

"I'm way too lazy for that." Marie smiled sweetly at the massive demon even as he scowled and slammed the door shut behind him.

"I don't know what you see in him." The redheaded human stared pointedly at the seductress.

"I don't know what he sees in *you*. " Belial rolled her eyes and walked towards a different door, leaving Marie alone with her thoughts.

Part 373a: Styx And Stones

It doesn't get any easier. I always think to myself that after hundreds of years of war and battle, the sight of mounds of bodies will finally stop disturbing me, but it doesn't. There's just a big difference between killing a planet full of people whom you can't see die, and walking onto a fresh field of bodies.

Heaven is... ruined. Completely ruined. The grass that once shone weirdly blue is now burned, with fires far in the distance that I can't even make out. The air is choked with smoke. Angels and demons lie in haphazard piles, each corpse telling a story of its own, of quick battles won in a decisive instant, or long battles that ended in a hard earned victory.

Victory... is this a victory? Without a doubt, the demons won this battle. Hell, they probably won the war. How long will it take the angels to regain their former numbers? Even so, if this is what Satan's end goal was, he truly is the Devil.

Well, I'm a hypocrite. He wanted to, and has all but succeeded in exterminating the angels, while I fully intended to exterminate the Volgrim. I guess I can't fault his logic.

"Jason!"

A male voice in the distance calls out, pulling me away from my thoughts. I squint, even using my Hypersuit's enhanced zoom to hunt for the source, but nothing is immediately visible as the speaker. Only once my positional audio tracking locates the voice does a red dot appear, making me turn slightly to the side. Probably a half mile away, I spot him. An angel, one wing missing, leaning on a long staff, with blood covering his body.

I don't bother trying to walk or run over the bodies, it would take too long. Instead I use my innate site-to-site teleportation and appear next to him instantly, startling the poor guy and making him topple over.

"Sorry. I forget most people aren't used to-" I find my words cut short by the sight that greets me. A half dozen angels are lying on the ground or sitting, all of them in various states of agony. Most of them are mortally wounded and won't have much longer to live if I don't heal them. Unfortunately, I expended most of my remaining energy that I took from the last container, and now there's almost nothing left.

"Oh... you're here." A weak voice speaks and I turn and gawk. Uzziel is being cradled by two other angels. Huge gashes are spread all over her chest, arm, and legs. There are hints of more damage poking out from the backside of her body. These didn't look to me like they had intent to kill, but rather that they were made to inflict maximum suffering.

"Uzziel." I breathe the name out and quickly kneel down. "Stay still. I'll heal you."

Before I can wordsmith, she raises her hand slightly. "Don't... bother. There's no point."

"Of course there is. I'll save as many angels as I can." My gaze hardens as I stare at her. "Don't get mooney with me."

"Jason... there's really no point. You don't understand. They're all gone. All the purebloods... I'm the last one."

Her eyes tear up, but she doesn't have the strength to wipe her eyes. A female angel next to her pulls up part of her bloodstained robe to dab at Uzziel's eyes for her.

"All of them? Every last one?"

"Yes. Even Gabriel... and Zeus. All gone. We lost. Maybe a hundred angels are left, and all are pseudo-angels except me. This is it."

She coughs dryly but doesn't seem to care about the pain. "I sent a few of the converted humans to look for survivors, but they're few, and nearly all badly injured. Even if you save us... there's no point."

I gently put my hand on her shoulder. "You can't think like that. Once humans die again, the pseudo-angels will be replenished. You are an archangel, you can lead them."

She stares at me, and I feel a deep sense of hollowness sent with just a gaze. "Jason... look around you. Think carefully. Earth was destroyed. Where are the billions of replacements?"

It takes me a moment, but slowly I feel a sense of dread come over me. "The resurrection project. It's... gone?"

She closes her eyes and shudders. "Yes. Gabriel was one of the three archangels who created the resurrection project. He was possibly more powerful than Zeus. He sacrificed himself to save what left of our kind. With his death, the project ended."

I slowly sink back and sit down, bowing my head. "This can't be real. Everything... it's all happening like it's been preordained. Earth is gone, the angels are crushed..."

Uzziel surprises me by giggling, a cute feminine sound that is cut short by blood in her throat. "You're funny. Jason, you could save us, but there's no point. All the humans who prayed to us were in the Church of Retribution. They died when Earth was destroyed. We can't replenish our numbers, and we can't regain energy as needed. We're... doomed."

Immediately I lock eyes with her. "Not so. Don't be fatalist. If I can pull out of a crushing depression, so can you. My clones and I have colossal amounts of energy. We can easily keep a hundred angels alive. Just a fraction of my energy would overwhelm all standing here now."

I don't bother telling her that I know this due to Cassiel in the future I come from. Cassiel was a good test subject. Her powers were overwhelming after the amount of energy I gave her. Between all of my clones and myself, I easily dwarf what I had available in the future.

"I don't want that. None of us do." Uzziel slowly reaches her hand over and rests it on mine. "I lost everyone I cared about. All my friends, my brothers, my sisters... they're gone. I don't want to live forever by myself."

"You don't have to. I'll be here. All these angels around you will be your new family."

Her smile brightens. "That's sweet of you... and in the past, I must admit I enjoyed being around you. I even felt a certain feeling when you came up here. I'm glad... to call you friend. But it's not enough, Jason. They're all gone now. I just... can't. I can't do it."

A lump begins to form in my throat, one that won't go away no matter how much I swallow. "Are... are you telling me to let you die? I... can't just do that."

"You can. And you will." She pulls her hand away from mine and her expression becomes more stern. "I am far older than you, Jason. I have the right to choose when I pass on. I know there is nothing but sleep for me... and I welcome it."

"That's it, then? We just part ways here?" I feel incredulous at this point. "What am I supposed to do?"

"You can't stop the future, Jason. Every time you've tried, you've failed. The future is inevitable. It's a hurricane, and you're a tree. You might dig your roots in, but eventually it will tear you from the ground and take you where it wishes. There's no preventing that which has already been decided."

I want to protest... but my mind goes back to Benjamin Brown. It was as if reality itself had to invent new ways to kill him. Almost fifty separate incidents nearly lead to his death, before an accidental electrocution ended his existence. If the universe wanted him dead, then perhaps there really was no way to stop him from dying.

"So this is it, then. Goodbye..."

Uzziel's breath catches in her throat. "W-wait. There's... one more thing. Gabriel, Raphael, and Michael... their rings. I have them."

Her words make me cease to breathe for a moment. "All three of them?"

"Yes. The demons, luckily, failed to take the rings of the archangels from Gabriel when he impaled himself. If they had known the powers these rings held, perhaps our luck would be worse." Uzziel reaches forwards with her other arm, one that's badly gashed up and shows me

the three rings she's wearing. "Take them. I can't safeguard my brothers any longer. They would want you to have them."

I reach over and hold her hand, gently plucking the rings from her fingers, one by one. "I understand. I'll take good care of them." My hand hesitates as I notice a fourth ring. "This... this is yours?"

"Yes." She smiles at me sweetly. "As a dying woman, I have only one last wish. I want for you to have my ring as well."

"Oh." I reach up and wipe my forehead. "I don't know... look, why not just let me heal you? You can keep their rings, and when they eventually awaken, you can speak with them again."

"They won't." She whispers it matter-of-factly. "They will only awaken when the time is right. Only when the need is great."

Great. She won't let me save her... no matter what I do.

This sucks.

"Take it with you now." She keeps her hand clasped in mine and gives a light squeeze. "Take my ring with you. When I perish, I will be with you, always."

Her sudden burst of emotion catches me off guard, and I glance up at the faces of the other angels nearby. All of them, naturally are human converts, but they seem to be attached to her. I can tell with a single glance that she is special to them. None of them wants to see her go.

"Fine. I'll do it."

It hurts. The fact that I'm going to let her die means that I've effectively given up, but she's right. At least, with her logic. I can't tell a woman who wants to die that she has to stay alive. She lost everyone she cared about. Forcing her to live in loneliness would only prolong her suffering.

"On one condition. I'm going to save any pseudo-angels that want to stay alive."

She smiles weakly. "I knew you'd say that. You're such a kind human."

I reach down and pull on her ring. "How will I know when you pass?"

"You'll know." She seems unusually reserved, but I'm not sure why.

I pull the ring off and a moment later, she gasps in pain as a surge of energy floods over into the ring in my hand. Her back arches up, and then she flops back down, her eyes fluttering briefly.

"Thank... you... Jason..."

Her eyes close, and then all goes still.

I... I feel so guilty. She didn't tell me merely removing the ring would kill her. Perhaps she lied, knowing that I wouldn't do it if I suspected the truth.

A female angel wipes at her eyes. "We tried to reason with her. We loved her, you know. She wasn't like the other purebloods. She always treated converts as equals. She always called us her good friends..."

I reach over and put my hand on the girl's shoulder. "Don't be sad. She's still alive, here in this ring, and someday, I'll make sure she is with her brothers again."

This seems to comfort the girl, and I quickly stand up and heal everyone around me. "If any of you wants to die, you'll have to do it on your own time. I've lost enough friends today. Come with me and I'll make a safe place for you."

They all nod reluctantly as broken limbs stitch back together and wings repair themselves. "This is the least I can do."

* * *

"It is done!" Hades smiled triumphantly inside of Satan. "A shame we could not finish before the Earth was destroyed, but more humans will surely die over the next few years."

"I can't believe you succeeded. I thought it would take the power of all the archangels." Satan stared at the filthy green river flowing before him. At that moment it was just a trickle, but someday it would be a raging torrent.

"It's not a matter of power or energy. In order to create a system for capturing souls, a death of incredible power, or a torrent of smaller deaths must occur at the same time. This was how Michael's death allowed us to create the resurrection system. He amassed significant power over his lifetime, getting people to pray to him, then he died and released the energy all at once. It was a flawless performance."

"And yet you betrayed him, in the end." Satan smiled to himself. *As I willed you to do.*

"I know not why I did it, but it felt satisfying." Hades murmured softly to himself. "Your power and methods are exemplary. You are a superior being compared to the gods and archangels."

"Oh, geez, the praise is too much." Satan waved his hand in the air. "You're making me blush."

"I find that hard to believe." The dark archangel simmered quietly. "One approaches. A familiar scent."

"Mmm." Satan straightened up and tilted his head over towards the approaching visitor. "Marie. What are you doing here?"

The redheaded human moved gracefully across the ground, crinkling her nose at the putrid green river. "Satan, what in the seven hells is this filth? I didn't know this labyrinth came equipped with a sewer system, nor that you were fond of inhaling its odors." She pinched her nose and breathed through her mouth for a moment, before sticking her tongue out in disgust. "Blech. I can practically taste death in my mouth."

"I can understand why. This is a river to trap souls, after all." Satan waved his hand in the air, flopping it around at the scene before him. "Welcome to the River Styx."

Marie raised an eyebrow with obvious interest. "Something about that name tells me it's not a sewer system."

"Indeed, it is not." Satan's face grew serious as he contemplated the muck flowing just in front of him. "This is my backup plan."

"Hmm?" Marie walked up beside him and nudged him in the arm, even while keeping her nose pinched. "Do go on, but make it snappy. Every second here brings me closer to death."

"Jason Hiro had several predictions regarding the future. Contrary to his desires, all of them have come true." Satan licked his lips as he stared emptily forwards. "There is only one prediction left."

"Your death. I've heard."

"Yes. My death. If things keep up, I may just die soon. I don't know when, and I don't know how, but it may happen. If I should pass, the forces of Hell will be leaderless, and lost. My careful manipulation that has created elite fighting forces will fall to pieces."

"Mmm. How so?"

Satan scratched his chin, slowly twisting a long strand of hair through his fingers before plucking it out. "I have been able to take the souls of those who die, those not taken to Heaven, and feed their essence to select minions. I have been able to do this thanks to the help of... a friend. For thousands of years, I have given the souls only to those whom I believed would be able to acquire great power. It has taken a toll on me."

Marie seemed unconvinced. "You look fine to me." She grimaced as the acrid fumes were making her eyes water and her throat dry. *Just get on with it.*

"Not a physical toll, but a mental one. Being a monarch for thousands of years, one that my people have come to fully rely on, has not been easy. I have made costly mistakes that resulted in the deaths of millions, even billions of demons. The guilt weighs on me."

Marie smiled slightly. "Sounds like you plan to die."

"On the contrary." Satan's eyes lit up as he jerked his head to stare at the puny human. "I intend to ascend and leave behind the fears and desires of mortals. This river will continue to do the work of collecting souls. I will leave the trivial matter of deciding who has earned their evolution to my third in command, Diablo. He is one of my most intelligent generals."

Marie stared at the massive demon carefully. "By 'ascend', you mean..."

"You're an intelligent female. If not now, someday you will figure it out."

"I see." Marie turned away from him to stare at the river. *I have no idea what this crimson baboon is babbling about.*

Satan turned away from the woman. "Once I ascend, I will become an unstoppable force. Only I am capable of this ascension, due to my unique characteristics. Once I take my place as the god of this universe, none will stand in my way."

"What then?" Marie sent a curious glance his way. "Don't you think you'll be bored, after a while?"

"Why would I be bored?" Satan's jaw slackened as he stared at her. "Having unlimited power will be a thrilling feeling, one unlike any other. I will be the first, the last, the omega and the almighty."

"I won't pretend to know what such a feeling is like... but I can only imagine it will be lonely." Marie finally released her nose and sighed deeply, ignoring the fumes she had started to grow used to. "I don't know what you're planning, but I hope for both our sakes you stay sane. Power like what you're talking about can drive a man to incredible fits of irrationality. You might destroy the universe."

"That would be a blessing, in many ways. The universe is full of filth. Humans, Angels, Demons, Volgrim... not a shred of decency among any of us. We would be lucky to be eradicated. Perhaps some alien species exists, far beyond where our eyes can ever hope to see, one that would be able to right the wrongs we've committed."

Marie smirked as she turned to walk away. "Now that, my dear devil, would be a feat worthy of a god. I should like to see that happen someday."

Satan remained silent, and soon she was at the door. "Nice talk, First Emperor. I hope this river thing works out for you. You're a more interesting man than any I've met before."

She left, and soon the Devil was alone with the dark archangel once more.

"It will all be for naught if he succeeds. I must make sure to survive long enough to see this through. If he comes up with a way to kill me, it's all over."

"You won't die so easily." The voice inside of Satan spoke with a tinge of pride. "That human hasn't a hundredth the will you possess."

Satan closed his eyes as an image of a young girl appeared within. "He is not the menace I fear most."

Part 374a:

"Commander Hiro, glad to see you survived." The Bitch of Britannia fans herself onscreen because the ambient temperature in her ship seems to be a bit above normal. Probably some issue with the climate controls. That, or she's having a hot flash, I'm not sure.

"Beatrix. It's been many years since we spoke. How are you?" Both of us ignore the fifty or so angels milling about behind me. I pulled as many survivors out of Heaven as I could find, but it was nowhere near a hundred. This is all that remains of the angelic species, and all of them are human converts.

Normally I'd go to the Bridge or my quarters to talk privately, but the message was flagged as informal, so I decided to have it in the mess hall. Frankly, I'm not in the mood for a serious conversation. I've had enough happen today. At least the mess hall has some soft music playing, it helps with my relaxation.

"I'm fine. Retirement has treated me well." Beatrix reaches down and takes a sip from a fancy Chinese cup in front of her. Knowing her, it's probably tea of some sort. "It appears things didn't go very well over the last twenty years."

"What would make you say that." I respond with a rhetorical question. "Was it the total destruction of Earth, the eradication of the angels, the reappearance of the Volgrim, or the fact they had a Death Star?"

"Don't be a smartass. We have to move past the failures. The good news is that Mars has been a military facility for humanity for a long time now. We have a lot of secret elements at play here." Beatrix sets the cup down and a pleasant expression comes over her face. "We actually had no counter to that battle station though, so it's a good thing you took care of it or we'd all be dead."

Her smile makes me feel unsettled. "Great. Glad to help." I decide not to correct her about who truly destroyed Refuge. After all, that would lead to more questions, and at this point it doesn't matter. I'll make sure Arthur's sacrifice wasn't in vain. "Beatrix... I know you've been in retirement, but-"

She cuts me off immediately. "I returned just in time to crush several thousand Volgrim ships that were launching an assault on Mars. That is all. Don't expect me to fight this war for you. You're the goddamn Supreme Commander, act like it." She leans back in her chair and looks away sullenly. "In the end, they will hate you no matter how you perform."

Her words have an edge to them. She is clearly filled with regret, and the way humanity dropped her during her election all those years ago must have hit her hard.

"I hope you don't blame yourself. There are many people who still respect the Bitch of Britannia. You saved Earth many times during the initial Volgrim invasions."

"I have my supporters, it's true." She turns back to look at me again, but her voice is neutral now. "Doesn't change anything. If I have to fight, it will only be for one reason, and that's to protect my home. Mars cannot and will not be destroyed. The Volgrim will be back, whether it takes one day or one century. If they come, I will fight them."

Relief floods over my face. "That's all I wanted to request of you. I don't want you to lead humanity's forces, and certainly not out of obligation. I just... I want you to be there for the people that believe in you."

"That's all I can do, Jason." Someone whispers something to Beatrix offscreen and she rolls her eyes. "Here we go again. It's always something. Take care of yourself, time traveler. I'll be in touch."

I nod at her and the screen goes blank a moment later.

I'm sitting at my table with a steak meal in front of me, but I barely feel hungry. I cut a piece of the juicy meat only to find myself asking if this is right. All the animals on Earth are gone. All the cows, chickens, cats, dogs... they're all gone. This isn't even a real steak, it's a fake approximation made by a replicator.

All the life on Earth is dead now... and it's because I was too weak. My power is massive, yet insignificant. Compared to the power of all the stars in the universe, I am nothing. Whoever created the universe is far greater than I will ever be.

I stare out the window at the stars and wonder to myself for a while. The Creator... the angels believe he or she existed at one point. Does the Creator still exist? Did they die? Are they in hiding? Why create a universe filled with hate and strife, death and destruction? Why create sentient species that only seek to kill each other?

I'm reminded of a conversation I had a long time ago. Boredom is the true enemy of immortal beings. Supposing someone were powerful enough to create a universe, what could oppose them? What could they hope to learn if they were omniscient? What could they seek to achieve if there was nothing left to achieve? Of what value is a score if you set the standards for that score yourself and you can break it with no effort?

I miss Arthur already.

* * *

Minutes pass, and I'm surprised as someone sneaks up behind me and rubs my shoulders. Of course, it barely takes me a second to realize who they are. "Amelia."

"How did you know?" She asks the question as if there is any other woman who would boldly come up and be intimate with me.

"Lucky guess." I shove a pea on my plate around with my fork, abusing the poor thing with malice in my heart. "They're dead. All of them."

"The angels." She doesn't ask it as a question. Moving around to my right side, she pulls up a chair and sets it right next to me, then sits down and leans against me, putting an arm around my back. "I was really worried about you."

"You had good reason to be. I... I almost gave up." I glance down at her and feel sort of depressed at how she enviously stares at the food on my plate. She'll never be able to appreciate the taste of it.

Amelia is quiet for a few moments. "I did too."

This surprises me. "You did? Why? You're always so cheerful and optimistic."

She shakes her head slowly and buries her face into my arm. "I'm not, actually. I just try to be. There's no reason to be sad or depressed all the time. Sometimes though, I just can't help it."

Amelia... she's never really shown any negative emotions in all the time I've known her. At worst, she might have shown some worry over what was going to happen to me, but not more than that.

"You seem like you're sad now." I leave the statement hanging in the air, and figure that if she wants to elaborate, she will.

She does. "Why shouldn't I be? I liked Earth, you know. I hoped you were wrong about the future. I thought maybe you'd change the future and Earth would be saved."

"It doesn't sound like Earth is the only thing you're worried about."

She pulls her head away from my arm and leans against me more gently now, nibbling on a fingernail. "Well... if you were wrong about the Earth, and the Volgrim... then the rest of the future is probably going to play out too."

"Maybe."

My simple response seems to make her want to keep talking. "If you were wrong about all that, then something big is going to happen. We're probably going to have to fight Satan."

I raise an eyebrow. " *We're* going to? If you don't fight him, then you won't be the one to kill him. That means that the future will be different."

She's wholly unconvinced. "You really think you can still change the future? Don't you see the futility yet? It's impossible. The future will always fix itself." She smiles wryly. "I mean, think about it. I don't know what your motivation was for traveling back in time, but if you change the past and that motivation changes, you won't have any reason to go back in time. And since you won't have any motivation, you won't go back, and thus you won't change the past anyway."

"You're talking about the Grandfather Paradox."

"Yeah." She loops her arm through mine and smiles up at me. "Don't you see? It's pointless. You can't change the future, because if you could, then you would erase the future where you time traveled. It would break reality."

I nod along slowly and think to myself again about Benjamin Brown. Reality itself fought to make sure he died. No matter how I saved him, or how many times I shielded him from harm, death found a way to come for him. Was he destined to die? Is changing the future futile?

"Human designated Jason Hiro, I have been following your conversation with the utmost interest." The music from the speakers in the ceiling cuts off, and a robotic voice chimes in from the ceiling, causing everyone in the mess hall to stare up in confusion.

Christ. It's Umi.

"Great. Don't mind us, just having an intimate conversation." I mutter the words just barely loud enough for Amelia to hear me, but apparently Umi picks them up loud and clear.

"Do not fret, I will not worry. I don't care about the feelings of an inferior life form in the slightest." Her biting wit makes me grimace visibly. "I am simply here to congratulate you on your recent performance during the destruction of Earth."

Now I'm confused, and so is Amelia. "Uhhh, who's that?" She stares up at the ceiling, baffled at the strange voice speaking from the heavens.

I roll my eyes. "I told you about her once. She's Umi, an artificial intelligence. She claims to be omniscient."

"Huh. Neat." Amelia now is totally mentally disconnected from the conversation we were having. Way to ruin the mood, Umi.

"I am a highly evolved life-form, not an artificial intelligence. From my perspective, you are the artificial intelligences. After all, you have no intelligence to speak of, meaning your definition of the term 'intelligence' is artificial and based on social constructs."

Oh my god *shut the fuck up*. This computer drives me up the goddamn wall. "Umi, please just get on with it. We're trying to enjoy a meal here."

"That does not seem to be the case. You are merely moving the food around on your plate, while the female homunculus beside you is unable to ingest such substances."

Amelia jerks her head up to look at me. *Homunculus?* Her lips mouth the words and I shrug.

"Just get on with it!" I yell upwards and realize now everyone in the mess hall is staring at me. Between the angels that arrived, Amelia, and several of my clones, everyone seems to be wondering what's going on. At least my clones understand who she is. This is going to be a pain to explain.

"As I stated, I wanted to congratulate you. You exceeded my expectations with regards to your performance defending planet Earth. You dealt with the first major catastrophe with flying colors."

I stare up at her blankly. "You do realize Earth was destroyed and the angels were basically eradicated, right? I'd hardly call that a success."

"You are correct, however my initial hypotheses substantiated that you were of such inferior intelligence that you would be unable to save all of humanity and all of the angels, leading to the total extinction of both, and there was even a 12.5% chance of you inadvertently eradicating both species yourself. Additionally, due to your sub-par mental acuity, I hypothesized that there was a 2.3% chance you and all of your clones would die during the Volgrim assault. You outperformed my expectations by substantial margins in all categories."

The entire hall is dead silent. Everyone simply stares at the ceiling with their mouths agape, including me.

Finally, after a full five seconds of blank staring, I relent. "Thanks for the praise, Umi. That uh... that really means a lot to me."

Umi makes an odd beeping sound. "I have detected, with a 45% threshold of probability, that you might be acting sarcastic right now."

"Wow, Umi, you're really good at this."

"I have detected, with a 68% threshold of probability, that you might be acting sarcastic."

"Oh my god! Shut up!" I bellow at the stupid goddamn supercomputer and she stops squawking for a few moments.

"That was decidedly not sarcastic. I am taking notes on your odd behavior currently. I recommend a psychoanalyst to determine if there are significant aberrations in your personality matrix." Umi beeps a few times before continuing. I don't bother interrupting, as I'm starting to feel dead inside. "In any case, that was only phase one of the level three calamity that humanity was to face. There is a second phase you must deal with. Based on your superb performance in

the first phase, I have every confidence that you will succeed at stopping ten percent of the incoming threats."

Finally, she says something useful and I can wipe the drool from the side of my mouth. "There's more to come? You must mean the Volgrim will return. We'll be ready."

Umi doesn't respond for a few moments, and when she does, her voice sounds really weird. "Hah! That's a laugh! This idiot thinks he can stop them! What a riot! I'll bet he also thinks-" The voice cuts off and Umi's normal voice returns. "Hmm, another anomaly in my personality subroutines. I will have to make some more adjustments. In any case, Jason Hiro, I will wait expectantly on your performance in the second phase."

"Great. Thanks for nothing." I lower my head and lightly bash it on the table in front of me.

"You are welcome." Her voice cuts off and the music continues at exactly the same spot it was before.

Amelia stares at me, dumbfounded. "You want to explain what just happened?"

A quick glance around the hall shows that literally everyone but my clones are looking at me expectantly.

"Not really, but I guess I might as well speak to an audience."

* * *

Nufaris sat on the bridge of the Dolfraxis, staring blankly at the stars that zipped past while his crew moved at warp 6. Putting distance between themselves and the Terran sector was a requirement after what had happened.

His right hand loosely held a small silver dagger, one of exquisite craftsmanship taken from a vault on Volgarius during the evacuation. Few knew of its origins, including himself, but still he admired it. On the handle, a design of a strange birdlike creature was etched, one unlike anything he'd ever seen on Volgarius.

From what he knew about the history of the Volgrim, taken from Unarin's memory recorder and the other top level files Nufaris had been able to access as leader of his race, Volgarius had been a barren planet compared to its predecessor. Volgarius Alpha, the original homeworld for the Volgrim, had been a rich and diverse planet, covered in trees and flowers, teeming with wildlife.

Only due to the incident at Melkian IV... Nufaris shook his head slowly. Humans were supposed to be the evil ones. In truth, after everything he'd learned, Nufaris had grown to loathe the history of his own people far more than any atrocity the humans might have committed.

It's probably for the best they destroyed our homeworld. Many of the weaker elements of our society were purged anyway, and much of our violent history was washed away.

What a history it was. Endless war for thousands, perhaps a million years. His kind had unlocked the secret of immortality, yet their numbers grew too rapidly without the population controls needed to sustain a society of immortals. It was their own undoing in the end.

"Executor, does something trouble you?" The first officer, Velvel, stared over at his commander emotionlessly. "It has been three cycles, yet you have not spoken to the crew other than to give orders."

"So what if I haven't?" Nufaris lowered his head to stare at his dagger. "What does it matter? We've lost. Their numbers are superior. Their technology is our match. They have abilities that bend the fabric of reality." Nufaris spoke softly, so the rest of the crew on the bridge would not be able to discern his exact words. "We were supposed to crush them with the might of Refuge. Billions of our brothers allowed their light to be extinguished so that we would have room to expand the weaponization of the assault platform. Were their deaths not in vain?"

Nufaris tilted his head up and stared back out at the vastness of space. "Unarin made a mistake in choosing me. I should have just taken our people and fled the stars, banishing the rage of our people to the ether. Our numbers would still be vast, and we might have found a planet to colonize. Revenge has done nothing but weaken us. It is a petty emotion, and one we should abolish."

Velvel sat quietly for a minute or so as both of them took in the serenity of the universe around them. "I am not so certain. The humans have not abandoned their emotions. They still have fear, anger, sadness, revenge, love, and many others. We consider them to be unenlightened, yet they have only lost to us in small ways, and crushed us in bigger ways. Indeed, we have destroyed their homeworld, as they destroyed ours, yet they can easily create a new planet suitable for life. They will rebuild and survive. We will stagnate."

Nufaris finally turned to look at his first officer, surprise in his eyes. "You're suggesting that they have something we don't."

"Only that emotions have not weakened them. Perhaps emotions have costs that are too great for a species to survive, but we would be deceiving ourselves if we said that a lack of emotions has made us stronger. Further, the lie would have a second layer of complexity to it, as revenge is an act, but one that we take in pursuit of emotions. To pursue revenge for the destruction of Volgarius, we must first admit that the loss of our homeworld angered us, and that it saddened us. After that, we must make the decision to assault the humans, in order to make them feel the same emotions we once did."

The first officer smiled, an expression he had never shown in front of the Executor. "In the end, we are lying to ourselves. We are only pretending to show no emotion. We still feel them, and perhaps more strongly than the humans do. I think that if you were to take any course of action now, it would be to allow our kind to stop lying to themselves."

Nufaris raised an eyebrow as he glanced around the ship. None of the other Volgrim were watching him, and none could hear this conversation, yet he felt as if all of their attention was on him.

"What should we do, then? How should we pursue such a course of action?"

"We prepare for a final assault against the humans. This will be the last one ever. We will surely perish, but we will make them feel our wrath." Velvel's smile tightened as his fist clenched and his arm trembled. "I... I lost many members of my house when Volgarius was destroyed. Friends. Family. I have never forgotten them. I will never allow myself to forget those emotions I experienced. If you asked me to commit a suicidal attack on the humans, I wouldn't hesitate."

The Executor allowed himself to smile too, though it was a forced expression. He merely wished to test out how it felt. "I laughed when we crushed Earth into dust. It was a feeling I would love to experience again."

"Executor, there is..." The communications officer spoke up suddenly, alarm in his voice. "...a call... on the subspace relay. This signature though, it's being broadcast on a channel I don't recognize."

Velvel and Nufaris shot a look at each other before glancing at their respective holopads.

"This encryption key. I recognize it." Nufaris breathed quietly. "P-patch it through. It must be a mistake."

The viewscreen on the bridge activated and a gasp erupted through the hall as the face of the former highest ranked Volgrim appeared.

"First Founder Unarin!" Velvel exclaimed in surprise as he leaned forwards in his seat. "We thought you had passed during the assault on Volgarius!"

The First Founder stared directly at Nufaris silently, as a strange looking bipedal automaton came into view. "I've been busy. Nufaris, I see you've gotten my people into a fine mess."

Nufaris opened and closed his mouth, as he stared not at Unarin, but the robotic lifeform beside him. "That's... that's..."

Unarin shook his head slowly. "This is not a Sentinel. This is the second version of the Gatekeeper protocol. I presume you have reviewed my memory logs?"

Nufaris lowered his head and stared at the floor. "I have. You... you wouldn't really reactivate the Sentinels, would you?"

"I would, I could, and I did." Unarin pursed his lips. "I expected things to turn out in the way they did. However, I have returned and as such I will be taking over the leadership of the Volgrim."

Unarin started to say something else, but he frowned instead. "Where are the other Founders?"

Executor Nufaris, current highest ranked of the Volgrim, felt a cold terror wash over him. "Th-they perished. An accident aboard Refuge during a routine maintenance test, several orbital cycles ago."

Unarin's eyes narrowed ever so slightly. "You would lie to the most powerful of all Volgrim? Foolish. I had thought better of you."

Nufaris stood up from his chair and glared at the First Founder. "How dare you call me a liar! You are a hypocrite! A usurper to that title! You are *not* the most powerful of the Volgrim!"

If Unarin was surprised, he kept it well hidden. "I am now. Step down, Nufaris. If you do not, I will make you."

The Executor slowly sat back down and glanced to the side. Every officer on the bridge was looking from him to Unarin, wondering what would happen.

I can't sacrifice the future of my species on petty power squabbles.

Nufaris sighed. "Do as you will. I hereby hand the power of the Volgrim back to First Founder, Unarin."

The first founder raised an eyebrow. "That's 'Executor Unarin', *Elder* Nufaris. Since I am the final remaining Founder, it makes little sense for me to have a numerical title. But then, I suppose that's why you changed your title too, isn't it?" Unarin's tongue snaked out of his mouth as he licked his lips. "I will get to the bottom of this, and then I will crush the humans."

The bridge was silent as the video feed cut off, leaving all to look from one Volgrim to the other, wondering what would happen next for their kind.

Part 375a: Dark Horse

April 11th, 2123.

It's been about two years since the Volgrim destroyed Earth. Still, they have yet to return. Once upon a time, today would have been celebrated as an Easter Sunday, but that is not what humanity does anymore. We no longer hold holidays or celebrations, as those were part of the old world. January 6th is the only day that we might call a holiday, but instead it is a solemn day... a day of remembrance. The day an alien menace stole forty billion lives from the collective numbers of humanity.

Earth... it's not a real planet anymore. It has long since cooled from the impact, aided by my wordsmithing, though now it's nothing but a scorched rock. The atmosphere is almost entirely gone.

My feet feel a crunching sensation as I walk across the barren planet, with Sensei and Amelia behind me. We can't hear the sound our boots make though, given there's nothing to transfer the sound in the near-vacuum of space. Amelia, interestingly, is wearing a hypersuit now. She wanted to come along, not that I could blame her. She loved this planet, as did I. Truth be told, I might be lying to myself about that little fact. If I loved the planet so much, why did I live aboard the Mothership?

Maybe I knew Earth was going to be destroyed. Maybe I wanted it gone. I don't know, but the fact is that what's done is done.

Sensei breathes slowly inside his hypersuit, as the audio transmitters between the three of us allow us to speak to one another. "Any sign of it?"

"Still looking." I curse Locate's fallibility in this instance. Locate isn't useful when the inanimate object we're looking for is buried under perhaps thousands of tons of rocks and debris. The Moon crashed directly onto this area, after all. Even the crown, which once helped me locate several powerful artifacts in the Labyrinth, is of no use here. Perhaps Arthur used his magic to hide the damn thing so we couldn't find it.

"Are we even in the right spot? Everything looks the same." Amelia groans as we walk around. No mountains are visible, the ground is scorched black as far as the eye can see, and the only thing that stands out are plumes of lava that shoot up into the sky, many miles away.

"Harold says he did a calculation based on the planet's orbital cycle, our approximate location compared to the Equator, and several other things I didn't understand. Arthur's blast came from around this area somewhere. We may have to dig to find Excalibur."

"Oh sure, let me just grab a friggin' shovel." Sensei grumbles under his breath, but we all hear him anyway, thanks to Centurion.

"I could try and wordsmith it out of the ground, but I'm not sure how to do that when Locate isn't telling me exactly where it is. Even my spherical vision can't penetrate this much rock and dirt."

Amelia comes to a stop and turns around to look at me. "Jason, listen... I know that guy was your friend or whatever, but it's just a sword. You can make one that looks just like it."

I nod slowly but lower my head. "Yeah, I can, but I can't replicate its magical properties. The sword itself is possibly the strongest magic weapon in the universe. In Arthur's hands though... his control over energy made it unstoppable. You saw what he did to Refuge."

Amelia shrugs and turns back to walking. Frankly, I find it weird that she doesn't remember Arthur at all. She once told me that Leviathan degrades her memory over time, but this is ridiculous. He's also confirmed to me that while she suffers deleterious memory degradation, he does not. And if he doesn't, then why hasn't he reminded her of who Arthur is?

Maybe Leviathan just doesn't care. Perhaps he's growing weary of the constant fighting, and doesn't like to see her consumed with anger or sadness. It's true though, she's much happier now than she was in the future that I came from, but I do still worry about her. I feel as if she carries the guilt of Earth's destruction on her shoulders, even though it wasn't her fault. She had no way to stop it.

Well, *she* didn't... I don't know about that Leviathan though. He told me once that the power of Wordsmithing was nothing compared to his own abilities. Seems like a cocky statement to me, but what the hell do I know?

Amelia finally sits down on a small boulder barely sticking out of the grounds and moans loudly. "We've been out here for hours! This is pointless! We're never going to find it! I'm bored!"

Sensei tilts his head away and chuckles, but I ignore him. "Just a bit longer. We need to find that sword."

Amelia leans back on the rock and stretches for a solid three seconds before standing back up again. "All right, but I'm going back to the ship. I wanna take a nap."

Amelia's not usually one to sleep in the middle of the day, but she can get cantankerous when she's bored. "Sure. Sensei and I will keep looking a bit longer."

Amelia starts to say something but yelps as the ground beneath her crumbles slightly and she falls back, plopping her back against the rock and rolling off it. "What the heck?! This

ground is weird!"

"That's to be expected. No human has ever walked on soil in this condition before." I smile at her little stumble, but then I give pause as I stare more carefully at the spot her foot sunk into. "That patch of ground... it looks off color, as if it was dug up."

Sensei nods and quickly walks over to it. "The coloring is certainly different. And this boulder, we haven't really encountered any whole rocks up to this point. That seems rather suspect."

All three of us look at each other for a moment before quickly stepping back. I aim my innate telekinesis at the rock and lift it up, ripping it from the ground and moving it a few feet away to the side.

Amelia walks up to the small crater and gawks at it. "Holy moly! There's a narrow hole that goes way down!"

I walk up to it and stare in disbelief. "This hole isn't natural. Someone must have dug it themselves."

It's a small hole, probably big enough for a small child to fall into if they weren't being careful, but too small for even Amelia to fit into. However...

" **Shrink.** " I utter a single word and feel my body and the hypersuit decrease in size until I'm about a quarter of my usual height. "I'm going to jump in."

Sensei nods at me but raises his palm up. "Wait, it's going to be pitch black in there. You'll want to make sure you can see around you."

It's then that I remember Sensei's body is always glowing. He never turns his glow off and usually wears a hypersuit to hide it, but I've seen him a few times without the suit. I'm not quite that scared of whatever hit him though.

"You're right. **Illuminate.** " I decide to make my armor itself glow as I look way up at the mountain of a man that I call my clone. "I'll be right back."

Walking over, I stare down into the hole and feel slightly anxious. It's not that I'm claustrophobic or scared of the dark, but I get the heebie jeebies when I think of big spiders or something being down in there. It's stupid, because those don't exist, and they couldn't have survived the Moon's impact, but the human mind can be irrational.

Also, I'm totally not scared of spiders.

Definitely not.

I hop down into the hole and feel a wave of panic as more than a second passes, then two seconds. My speed is increasing, and the drop is way further than I expected.

Four seconds. Five. Six.

It takes almost ten seconds before I feel my insect brain scream in terror as the ground rushes at me.

Wham!

I smash into the ground with a heart-wrenching impact, though I'm perfectly fine thanks to the Hypersuit. When I raise my head, I can't see the sky outside at all. It's pitch black.

"I'm in."

I speak into my mic, but only get crackling in response. I guess even advanced technology will have a hell of a time piercing that much dirt and rock.

"Centurion, how far below the surface are we?"

The AI doesn't even hesitate. "ROUGHLY 1,300 FEET BELOW THE SURFACE, OR ONE QUARTER OF A MILE."

Great, at least I'm not totally alone down here. I still have my artificial friend, and he's *such* a conversational fellow.

A quick glance around surprises me. My armor illuminates quite a large half-spherical cavern, one that is totally flat underneath me, and almost perfectly circular above.

In fact... this isn't 'almost' perfectly circular, it *is* perfectly circular. I take a few step forwards as I'm looking around and feel my foot kick something.

When I look down, I feel a rush of emotion overcome me. Arthur's body... it's right here, just in front of me. I didn't see him when I landed, but his body is in fairly good condition, as if the vacuum here and the lack of insects and critters preserved him. His skin is still starting to degrade but... he's in... relatively good condition.

He's dead though.

Absolutely, totally dead. He's gone. There isn't a chance I can bring him back.

I kneel down and touch his shoulder. "Arthur... I know you can't hear me but... I'm glad you found peace at last."

Just a few words. That's all I can do. I ponder for a moment if I should take his body somewhere and bury him, but I guess this is the closest thing to a tomb he'll be able to get anyway, and he's buried on the planet he died trying to save. It's fitting in a way. His body must have survived the Moon's impact thanks to that aura he told me about.

He really was a tough son of a bitch.

After dwelling on what to do with his body, my heart suddenly turns frigid as I take a step back in shock.

Excalibur is gone. Someone has taken it.

Who? Who would do that?! How would they know about it?

I know *why* they would, after all. If they knew about Excalibur, then they would know about its power. If Satan could overcome its demon-slaying properties, then in his hands it would be a fearsome weapon.

Could Satan survive in the vacuum present on Earth? I find that hard to fathom. Satan may be a demon, but even he needs air to breathe.

Heh, actually, that's an interesting thought. If I do end up fighting him, that might prove useful to remember.

No! Wait! Stay focused! Someone took Excalibur, but who? Who would do such a thing?

I don't know. There's too many possibilities. Whoever it was, they'd need the technology to survive in a total vacuum. Shit, that might even make the Volgrim a possibility, or someone among humanity.

I'll have to worry about it later. For now...

" Return. "

I teleport back up to the surface and the other two jerk back in surprise. Sensei is first to speak.

"Did you find Excalibur?"

"I found Arthur. Excalibur wasn't with him."

Sensei stares at me, though I can't see his expression inside the Hypersuit. "Someone took it, then."

It wasn't a question. Both of us share a thoughtful nod.

"We need to find out who. The last thing we want is a surprise on our hands, especially at an inopportune moment."

Amelia shakes her head. "Maybe one of your clones took it? Did you ask anyone before you left?"

I shoot a glance at Sensei, but quickly wave the thought off. "Unlikely. I kept Arthur a secret from everyone. Even Sensei and you didn't know until Arthur blasted the Moon. The number of

people who even knew of his existence were small, though if one person knew, they could have leaked the knowledge to someone else... but... then again..."

A thought disturbs me. " **Locate.** " I mentally aim my mind at Arthur's body, and am able to sense him immediately. " **Locate.** " I aim my mind at Excalibur, but find nothing.

Sensei realizes what I'm doing. "Excalibur is totally gone, isn't it?"

"Someone might have taken it and put it inside an anti-energy field. I can't locate things inside of those."

A small wave of anger fills me. If I had tried looking for Arthur sooner, I might have been able to find him. Instead I focused on Excalibur, thinking that it would be beside its owner anyway, and that Arthur's body would have been blown away by the Moon's impact.

Then again, I've been looking for Excalibur since shortly after we finished relief efforts. Someone must have taken it immediately after the Moon impacted, or right around the time I cooled Earth down.

The three of us stand in our small circle and slowly wonder about this theft. Who could the culprit be?

* * *

Hawkeye stood before the crew of the first exploration vessel of the Planet Revival team and smiled proudly. "This is it, guys! Just twenty more minutes, and we'll finally arrive at our destination!" He held the glass in his hand up, as did the entire audience of four hundred.

"It's been a long time comin'!" A crewman yelled out and everyone nodded along with him.

"Well said! We're gonna make history!" Another female staffer cheered and the mood became more energetic.

Hawkeye's smile faltered. "Let's not be too cheerful now. This is a grand day in the future of humanity, but we can't forget the true importance of this mission. Earth, as we all know, was destroyed by the Volgrim two years ago. This planet means a new beginning for humanity. Mars is merely a substitute, but it will never be able to house humankind as Earth once did. It's far too remote from the sun, and its seasons are chaotic. Even with terraforming, we are only making it's hellish landscape more bearable."

He strode forwards and turned to gaze out the forward viewport at the stars racing past them. "I come from a future ruled by tormentors and devils. I come from a future in which the demons placed humanity into small bubble worlds, leaving them as toys for the demons to lord over and tear to shreds when their homicidal urges needed a release. I come from a future where humanity had only just started to fight back... and we were winning."

Hawkeye lowered his glass and took a sip. "But it was a series of hollow victories. What good is a victory when there is no prize? Earth was already destroyed, humanity was still trapped in an endless hell, and the demons were an unending torrent. For every demon we killed, ten more sprung up in their place. Perhaps, given time, we could have found a way to counter them, but... I doubt it."

The entire crew's mood was sullen now and the cheering was nonexistent. Everyone listened to the clone of the Supreme Commander with rapt attention, for none wished to interrupt.

He turned back to stare at the crowd, seeing all those same familiar faces among him that he had grown used to over the last several years. Only one face wasn't there, but she had long since met an unfortunate *accident*.

"Some of you may find this hard to believe... once, I was a young man, and I was... alone. I had no friends, no drive, no energy. I had no reason to live, and allowed myself to be cryogenically frozen for the sake of science. I did this because I believed that my life was worth so little, that if I died during my freezing, at least it would aid the knowledge of mankind in some small way."

Hawkeye felt tears well up in his eyes, but he quickly turned and wiped them away. "I no longer feel that way anymore. I have friends here, people that I have learned about and lived with for half a decade. I know the names of every person aboard this ship. I know the life stories of most of you, and even some things I'd actually rather not have learned." He tilted his head back and glanced at the head engineer. " *Why* did you have to tell me about your foot issues?"

The man smiled nervously as the crew chortled to themselves.

"But really, this is what it comes down to. We aren't just making a habitable world, we are going to fundamentally alter the course of history. The Original, the one I am cloned from, has given up. He does not believe history can be changed, but I do! If we can create a world far from the reach of the demons and the Volgrim, one that we can enhance over time and make into an impenetrable fortress, the demons will never be able to hurt humanity again! They won't be able to stop us! We will expand and colonize the galaxy!"

He took a breath and smiled. "Well, possibly the whole universe, but let's call that a long term goal."

A few people chuckled at him, but it was all in good fun. Everyone aboard Exploration Vessel 1, the U.S.S. Stonewall knew that their commander was a man with a heart of gold. He truly cared about them and would ensure their safety, no matter what.

"Ten minutes, commander!" A man turned to look at Hawkeye from his station at the monitoring array, excitement filling his eyes. "We're almost there!"

"That we are." Hawkeye raised his glass up one final time. "A toast! To Earth! To humanity! To the future of civilization!"

"Hear hear!" The crowd cheered again as they clinked their glasses among one another and swallowed their drinks in one or two gulps.

Hawkeye walked over to the officer at the monitoring array and leaned over to look at the scans. "Are the preliminary scans available yet?"

"Yes, sir." The officer tapped a few buttons and an image of Revival appeared, its green atmosphere hazy and difficult to make out given the fact they were still just under a light-year away. "I'll have more detailed scans available in a minute or two, sir."

"Keep me posted." Hawkeye walked away from him and over to the new head of the medical section, Beverly Cruz.

"Commander, that was an excellent speech you gave." She smiled demurely at him and he smiled back. "It really got my blood pumping."

"Down, girl. There's still a chain of command here, and we've got the whole crew watching." Hawkeye lightly touched her arm and she casually looked away, as if she didn't care at all.

"Oh, you're such a charmer. After the celebrations, why not come by the medical bay and I'll give you a checkup?"

Hawkeye puffed out his lips in a mock display of pouting. "But... but Miss Cruz, you've already given me so many checkups this month. Can't I catch a break?"

She leaned towards him seductively and lightly touched his chest. "You're too big and strong to catch a break. I'll be seeing you, *commander*."

She started to walk away, but a loud cry of surprise erupted from the monitoring array, as the officer turned back and yelled at Hawkeye. "Commander! Scanners have detected multiple unidentified objects in orbit around the planet! Something is already there!"

Hawkeye's expression darkened in an instant as he walked over to the scanning section. "Put it onscreen."

The screen lit up and zoom was enhanced to maximum levels, but Hawkeye could barely make out the blurry mess. "Pull us out of warp. Keep us on the edge of the star's system. I need to contact home base."

They dropped out of warp, but the officer's voice quickly filled with dread. "Something is scanning us! Attempting to block- ah, it succeeded! This... this is..."

Hawkeye took a sharp breath as he stepped away from the screen. "Volgrim. They... they knew about this planet? How? How?! We need to get out of here!"

The communications officer just a few stations away spoke up, her voice nearly a whisper. "Commander Hawkeye... we're being hailed."

Hawkeye didn't even get to give an order as the screen lit up, a face appearing before him and all the rest of the crew.

He fell to his knees. "Unarin... you're alive?! You were supposed to have died when Volgarius-!"

Unarin interrupted him. "Talk is cheap. Your vessels are mine now. Resist, and you'll pay the price."

The video feed shut off and the monitoring officer nearly jumped out of his seat. "Ten bogeys on the way! The Volgrim are sending ten heavily armed interceptor-class warships right at us!"

Hawkeye glanced around him, taking the scene around him in a second. This was an exploration vessel. It had no weapons at all, other than mining lasers. All his friends would be slaughtered if the Volgrim caught them. That, or they'd be imprisoned and tortured.

Beverly...

He turned to gaze at the woman he loved. Fear was on her face, and the crew around him stared, trying to figure out what their brilliant commander would do.

"Warp 8, get us out of this system. Burn all the emergency Trifrancium, go as far as we can, then I'll open a portal back to Earth and seal it behind us. It's... it's the only way."

"Affirmative!" The navigation lieutenant relayed the orders to the rest of their ships, even as a hundred other blips appeared on their radar, rushing towards them from Revival.

Hawkeye's heart filled with rage. *How did they learn about our expedition?!*

A moment later, the ship blasted to warp speed.

If there is a god, spare my crew!

* * *

Unarin gazed evenly at the image of the fleeing ships, as a seven foot tall metal being walked up to him. "Executor, the human ships have jumped to Warp 8. Based on our preliminary scans of their fuel reserves, we anticipate they will flee to within a few lightyears of this planet and create a portal to return to Earth."

He turned to look at the automaton. It had a decidedly feminine appearance and voice modulator, which made sense given he had deliberately uploaded the brain of his female

assistant Muuxunu into it. Still, she had not complained. She understood what her purpose was, and she was glad to fulfill the orders asked of her by the highest authority of the Volgrim.

"As expected. Humans are nothing if not cowards. They only fight battles they know they can win, or they fight if cornered. They always flee when a true threat appears."

The Executor tilted his head towards a bio-pod that held the body of a Volgrim he had once considered worthy of being his successor. "What say you, Nufaris? Should we pursue them? They're showing the same cowardice you did when you fled their system."

Unarin let a smile trickle across his mouth. "Ah, I had nearly forgotten how hard it must be to speak in your position. Unending mental torture for the rest of eternity, so long as that pod draws power. Never mind, it wasn't a question anyway."

He turned back to his metal assistant. "Gatekeeper, order our interceptors to jump to Warp 9.3. Locate the humans' probable exit point, and lie in wait half a light-year away. When they open the portal..."

She nodded. "Understood, Executor. We will prepare the energy enhancement tunnelers at once."

Unarin turned back to his screen. "So sharp. That's why I chose you, of course. That and your limitless loyalty. Unlike... a certain other traitor."

He stared stoically at the screen before him, even as the planet's raging methane storm buffeted his facility. Images of his brothers and sisters, his fellow founders appeared unbidden in his mind. "Trayza... Cinculu... Cuanali... I will not forget you. Your valiance during the Great Wars allowed us to reshape our society, but you were cast away by... by this backstabber. And... Dosena..."

He lowered his head and stared at the ground. "I am a hypocrite. I cast you aside when I no longer needed you, yet now I wish for your company again. I can only pray the humans gave you mercy in the end... the mercy the true leader of our people deserved."

The Executor raised his head up. "Gatekeeper, tell me... have you taken any time to read the material we downloaded from humanity's archives?"

His assistant stared ahead silently for a few moments. "Affirmative. What material would you like to peruse, Executor Unarin?"

Unarin's mouth slowly crept into a toothy smile. "Tell me the human's story about the Trojan Horse."

Part 376a: Mulgris

Amelia held the plate of mashed potatoes in her hand and scrunched up her nose, glancing at the door to make sure Jason wasn't walking in. Sitting on her bed inside of her private quarters aboard the Mothership, this was one of a few private places where people would at least knock before entering, but this was a sacred ritual and one she had felt nervous about since she first started performing it. Her heart pounded as she reached over with a fork and tentatively lifted a small amount of the white mush and raised it to her lips.

"H-here goes..."

She opened her mouth and quickly stuck the food inside, closing up and chewing slowly as the nausea came to her in waves. Finally, she swallowed and her entire body shook as she forced herself not to tear up again.

"You really shouldn't force yourself, princess." The dragon inside of her sighed slowly. "I don't see why you do this."

Her lip quivered and she lowered her head and blinked hard before raising it back up. "This is for a good reason... Levy. I can't eat with my husband. Just once... I want to sit and eat like a normal person."

"Mmm." Leviathan kept his disapproval to himself. "You're certain he's tried all the possible words?"

"Yeah." She stared in disgust at the lump of juicy steak on her plate and gingerly pressed the fork down on it sideways, carefully tearing off a small piece. "It just doesn't work. Not 'taste', not 'fix', nothing. Every synonym in the book."

She raised the meat to her mouth and the stench of the filth almost made her recoil in disgust. "I don't get it! I could devour a human at one point, but this piece of cooked meat is so gross!"

Leviathan watched silently as she quickly jammed the meat in her mouth, almost breaking the fork as she did so, before yanking the implement back out and barely keeping the chunk of animal flesh in her mouth. This time, her eyes did water. Meat was really the worst. Not just because it tasted terrible like all the other food, but because meat especially reminded her of her life before Jason, and the guilt always came back in overwhelming waves of pain.

After barely chewing it twice, she swallowed and choked, grabbing a glass of water nearby. Thankfully, water didn't affect her, but she simply didn't usually need it. Now was different, as

she chugged the glass down and sighed with relief.

"Why can't the food just taste like water? It would be so much better."

The dragon inside of her appeared in her mind's eye and raised a massive eyebrow. "That would be possible, you know. He could wordsmith the food to taste like that."

Amelia stared blankly ahead for a few moments before setting the plate down beside her. "Oh. That's uh... smart, actually."

"I'm an ancient dragon, millions of years old. I should hope so." Leviathan seemed to sink inside of her for a moment as he contemplated something. "I am... fearful."

"Hmm? Why?" Amelia rubbed her belly, the spot where she always 'felt' Leviathan inside of her.

"Jason seems to have given up hope on changing the future. He seems to believe that you will kill Satan and that will be the end of it."

"And you don't think it is?" Amelia flopped backwards and laid down on the bed, while her legs continued to hang off the side. "I still recall you have a personal grudge against that demon. Wouldn't you like to settle it, once and for all?"

Leviathan hesitated before responding. "That grudge... it is from thousands of years ago. I have said this many times, princess. I do not care about such old trifles. Besides, I am not so certain that in your current state you could defeat him."

Amelia glared at the ceiling above her. "You don't believe in me? Rude! I'm way stronger than Jason, you know! He told me he nearly defeated Satan once."

"Not he, but his hypersuit. Jason was also essentially killed by Satan. I would hardly call that a resounding victory." Leviathan stewed for a moment. "There is... also the matter of the Satan I knew, a young whelp with a dark future before him, and the leader of the demons that he has become. He has had thousands of years to mature his abilities. The gift of evolution, I gave that to him. I enhanced his abilities, thinking only of how he would keep his promise and free me, but deep down I knew he would not."

Amelia was incredulous. "You think he's more powerful than you after all these years?"

Finally, Leviathan burst into a fit of laughter. "Ha! Hahaha! I wouldn't say that for a second! Not a chance!" His deep voice bounced around in her mind, echoing like an organ in an empty church. "But, while he could never possibly hope to defeat me, by the same metric, my powers that flow inside of you are necessarily weakened due to your small frame. If I were to channel all of my power inside of you, your mind would snap. You would not be the one that I have grown to-

Leviathan stopped talking and suddenly seemed bashful. "Never mind. In any case, facing him as you are would likely end in defeat. Think too of Jason's feelings. If Satan were to kill you, how would Jason feel? Would you want him to be crushed by grief?"

Amelia sat back up and scratched the back of her head. "I think you're being overly dramatic. Think, Levvy! If I'm alive in the future, and time is clearly continuing to move towards the future that Jason comes from, then I can't die! If I die, that's a paradox!"

"The grandfather paradox, yes, so I've heard. I'm not convinced. Unlike the demons, I am capable of understanding complex theories. Time travel is riddled with uncertainty and guesswork. Never assume anything is true until you have confirmed it for yourself."

Amelia stood up, ignoring the food and leaving it sitting there. "We'll worry about that stuff when the time comes."

Briskly, she walked over to her dresser and pulled out her little blue hair bow, the one Jason always smiled at. She was a woman after all, and she could tell with the subtle glances he gave her what he liked and what he didn't. Words weren't necessary.

After adjusting it in the mirror, she walked out the door and locked it behind her. "I wonder where he is."

Leviathan sent out a cursory search pulse. "The bridge. As always. That male is quite the lazy workaholic."

"That doesn't make any sense."

"*He* doesn't make any sense." The dragon grumbled to himself and Amelia skipped along down the corridor, occasionally using her superhuman speed to dash down a straightaway when nobody was looking. It wasn't that she was afraid of being seen, it just didn't seem ladylike to appear to be in a rush.

A few minutes later, she arrived on the bridge. "Yoo-hoo! Jason!"

Her voice lilted cutely, but after taking a few steps forwards, she quickly realized she had stumbled into chaos. People were moving around in a hurry, and the viewscreen was lit up with one of Jason's clones.

"We don't have time! Hurry up and open the wormhole! They'll be here in less than a minute!" The clone onscreen was sweating profusely and he seemed extremely frightened. "They're going to blow us out of the air! We can't fight with ships like these!"

"Calm down, Hawkeye. Make sure to set a waypoint. Once we pull you through and close the wormhole, we'll be able to open another one there later on once our forces are prepared."

Jason's right hand was curled up in a fist and he was gritting his teeth. Obviously something serious was going on.

"Jason? What's happening?"

He barely glanced at her. "Not now! This is a crisis! Hawkeye, on my mark, I'm going to have all the clones wordsmith at the same time! Get ready!"

Amelia looked around in confusion and quickly darted over to a terminal showing a readout of the conversation log. Using her superior mental acuity, she sped through the words and turned back to stare at the viewscreen in shock.

Leviathan had read it as well. "An ambush at Revival. Even I didn't anticipate this. The Volgrim are not to be trifled with."

"How did they find out about the planet?" Amelia asked the question quietly, but didn't expect an answer. Everyone was far too busy.

"Now! **Wormhole!**" Jason bellowed as did five other clones on the bridge and many others across the cosmos. The viewscreen switched to a half view of Hawkeye and another half of the wormhole opening up beyond the orbit of Pluto, its size quickly scaling to be big enough for a Cruiser-class starship to fit through.

Jason and his clones stumbled forwards and gasped as a flood of energy left their bodies. "There! It's open! Get through now!"

He didn't have to ask twice. Amelia watched several other screens that showed Hawkeye's exploration force quickly rush towards the portal at maximum impulse speeds, even as multiple red dots rushed towards their location.

A moment later Hawkeye's eyes were frantic. "We're through!"

Jason and his clones yelled out again. "**Seal!**"

Amelia breathed a sigh of relief as the hole in space rapidly shrank behind the exploration force. "That was a close one."

Everyone in the room breathed a little bit easier as the hole that would have let the Volgrim invade sealed up behind the exploration force.

"Well done, guys." Jason smiled jovially at everyone around him. "Let that be a lesson, never underestimate the intelligence collection capabilities of the Volgrim. I don't know how they found out about Revival, but now that they've taken control, we'll have to look elsewhere to-"

One of the clones jumped slightly in alarm. "The wormhole! It isn't closing up!"

Amelia tensed up when she saw what was going on.

"Oh... no..."

* * *

Unarin blinked as the newly acquired teleporter technology beamed him aboard the small but nimble Control Ship. "How unpleasant."

Unlike the other twenty ships in his small assault fleet, the Control Ship could only seat 5 or so beings, but as a tactical decision, he had only brought two others with him. Sleeping quarters were not needed, but he did have a meditation lounge installed for his personal comfort. The other two aboard would need no such luxuries.

He walked the short distance down the cramped hallway and arrived in the cockpit, where the two automatons sat, fiddling with various buttons and other such controls. "Gatekeeper, are the preparations complete?"

The 'female' cyborg responded promptly. "Yes, Executor. All Sentinels are charged and armed for combat."

The other one, unlike his former assistant, had no biological heritage. It was a purely artificial construct. Despite this, it still retained several irritating personality quirks, as did all of the other Sentinels.

That's why they are impossible to control.

Unarin kept his calm as he made sure not to ignore the other one. "Mulgris. I was surprised you asked to stay aboard the Control Ship. I had assumed you would want to fight on the frontlines."

"As if I had a choice in the matter." The mechanical voice that rasped back held an unpleasant hiss. "You must think of me as an inferior intelligence. Turning my back to you, only for you to wrench a knife in. Do you think we have forgotten the Melkian IV incident?"

Unarin's mouth felt dry. "No. Of... of course not. You must understand, the times were different back then. The Volgrim were a different people, fearful of the power of-"

Mulgris hissed, making Unarin stop talking. "I don't wish to hear your excuses. This new Gatekeeper is a shallow imitation of the former. If you think it has a chance of performing its functions, you must have grown more stupid in your old age."

The Executor of the Volgrim lowered his head and pressed his fingers together. "She is merely here to coordinate the assault. That is all. I would have chosen a more intelligent subordinate if I wished to deceive you."

"Your words are a poison to my receptors." Mulgris tilted its head down and gazed at its metal hands. "I should find the tearing apart of these 'humans' to be quite enjoyable, but

instead I must stay here and keep a sensor locked on you, due to your untrustworthiness."

Unarin felt his body twitch slightly. "If you are so distrustful of me, why not kill me now?"

The construct made a choking sound. "Kuh huh... to reform the Sentinels... you must be truly desperate. If these humans are such a threat, then it stands to reason that you have long been at death's door. You no longer possess the power to resist us. You must be feeling truly suicidal."

Mulgris' hand shifted, and its form melted and transformed into a razor sharp blade. "After we deal with these life forms made of carbon and other soft elements, we will dwell on how to deal with you."

The ship blasted forwards at Warp 8, racing the few lightyears towards the wormhole that was being held open by the new technology.

"I'm still surprised you were able to analyze the properties of the human's magic to devise counters to it. And... so quickly at that." Unarin changed the topic, feeling uneasy about what they had been discussing before.

"Trivial. The Volgrim have truly lost their keen edge. Once you would invent new branches of physics if it meant it had a chance to stop the Sentinels, yet look at you now. You didn't even understand the humans' transporter technology. Such a basic system." Mulgris' voice held a strange anger behind every word. "They call it *magic*. How quaint. The implication being that it is an unknowable force without limitations. Indeed, it has many weaknesses, and for my kind, manipulating matter is trivial."

Mulgris shifted the bladed hand back into its normal form and turned its head to stare at Unarin. Its red irises were unblinking, and could hardly even be called 'eyes'. They were merely imitations, created by the far-too-brilliant-for-their-own-good scientists at the original research station to instill fear in those the automatons fought in the field. Little was scarier than something that seemed familiar, but held an insidious undertone to it.

The fear, however, had little to do with their eyes.

"I've been meaning to ask, but I have been so... busy. How is Dosena?"

The construct continued to gaze at Unarin without wavering, but he held his ground. "She died in battle."

His sentence was short and simple, but Mulgris didn't seem to believe him. "Against the humans? Perhaps they are more fearsome than the reports have indicated. I find it unlikely she would lose to lifeforms that had yet to unlock the power of bio-engineering."

Unarin sighed, finally allowing himself to show a tinge of emotion. "We were unprepared for the humans' control over the power of magic. Dosena died allowing our forces to escape."

Mulgris turned its head back to the forward viewscreen. "I never expected you to lie, Unarin. Your words say one thing, but your biometric signature says another. I wonder what really happened to the Scourge of Melkia."

Unarin didn't get a chance to retort. Muuxunu spoke up, interrupting their discussion. "Arriving at the wormhole in ten seconds, Executor."

The three of them waited as the seconds ticked by. Finally, the ship decelerated and Unarin glared in confusion. "The wormhole is too small to pass through. We'll never be able to get the fleet to the other side."

"We can only stabilize it, Executor. I apologize for our incapability of expanding its perimeter." Muuxunu chirped sadly but quickly righted herself. "What are your orders?"

"I'm not sure." Unarin stared at the hole in confusion. "It's just barely big enough for the Control Ship to pass through, but the rest of our fleet will be unable to cross over."

Mulgris leaned forward and pressed a prompt on the control pad. A transmission signal beamed out to all the other ships nearby. "We are unable to proceed. Leave the fleet behind and shift your forms to subspace mode."

Unarin looked at the Sentinel with confusion evident on his face. "Subspace mode? What is that?"

The powerful construct was all too happy to let a small bit of pretentiousness slip into his voice modulator. "Sentinels can shift their forms, *Executor*. Warp travel may be impossible for us as we are now, but you'll find that normal sublight travel through space is no barrier to us."

As he spoke, the viewscreen shifted to show thousands of tiny masses evacuating the massive ships they had been using to travel to the wormhole. As if they were a hivemind, all of the beings swarmed together and flew at the wormhole, passing through it with ease.

"And now we follow." Mulgris glanced at the Gatekeeper and she quickly tapped several buttons, moving them towards the wormhole to follow along with the swarm.

Unarin leaned against the bulkhead behind himself.

It is unlikely I will live to regret activating the Sentinels.

Part 377a: Awakened Terror

"What the hell are those?" Beatrix paced back and forth in front of the Mars base tactical viewscreen. Several video feeds were being directed to her at once, and her eyes flicked over them intently even as the other senior officials and politicians wrung their hands together or barked orders. On the screen, thousands of small looking objects were moving at sublight speeds towards the last planet in the Sol system, Pluto, and would be passing it soon.

Beatrix was there only on advisory duty, but a sinking feeling in her gut told her that her advice wouldn't be of much use. She had no idea what they were up against.

An official nearby was the first to respond, but unlike her, his voice was filled with curiosity more than uncertainty. "We're not sure, but they vary in size from five feet long to forty feet. They resemble the shape of small tactical interceptors, but some are far too small to be crewed. They might be drones."

"Drones, huh? I know the Volgrim suffered a major defeat a few years ago, but if their numbers are so low they're resorting to drones, this is either a very good omen, or a bad one." Beatrix rubbed her palms together nervously. Something just didn't feel right. "Send out our own interceptors, but start with the Dartfighters. They're nearly indestructible, and unmanned, so they're likely to be the best option for scouting out the Volgrim forces."

A commander nearby nodded, but he was the leader in this situation and he had other ideas. "I agree, but we only have a thousand Dartfighters left. Send in an auxiliary force of three thousand crewed Interceptors. Keep them in reserve and only move forward if these drones prove to be dangerous."

"That should be fine, Francisco." Beatrix finally stopped pacing and watched the screen closely as the Dartfighters moved forwards to attack the incoming invaders. It took several minutes for the fleet to arrive, and when they did, the results were unexpected.

"Dartfighter down." A female analytics officer spoke up. "And another. And another. Zero of the unidentified enemy craft have been neutralized. Two more Dartfighters down."

While she watched as the battle summary was being broadcast, Beatrix gasped and covered her mouth with her hand. "Did that one just change its shape?"

Indeed, it had. It morphed into a needle-like object and lanced directly into a Dartfighter, entering it and destroying it from the inside-out before reforming and targeting another.

Francisco turned to his communications officer. "Order a retreat for the crewed interceptors. We're going to blast the enemy bogeys from a distance. They appear to be melee range fighters, like the Dartfighters."

"Yes, commander." The crewman relayed his seniors' orders and the blips from the human side moved back, while the Dartfighters continued being shredded.

"One enemy bogey down!" A voice yelled and everyone felt their breathing catch as a quick replay showed a Dartfighter ramming into one of the enemy contacts, smashing it into several pieces.

"Good. They aren't invincible." Beatrix released the breath she had been holding and sighed with relief.

A moment later, the debris from the enemy ship moved slightly, pulling itself back together and reforming before continuing to move deeper into Human space.

"You were saying?" Francisco spoke curtly, but there was no mockery in his eyes. "We're definitely going to need the Supreme Commander's assistance with this enemy."

* * *

Mulgris stared blankly ahead, as its mechanical face tended to do, and monitored the battle. "I am receiving reports that the humans sent out an unmanned attack force."

"Ah yes, those must be the ramming ships."

Mulgris didn't bother to respond. "They are being dispatched. A shame, for I had hoped the first encounter would make them throw caution to the wind."

"Your bloodlust is truly insatiable." Unarin crossed his arms and stared at the screen with a bored look in his eyes. "I remember when those little ships shredded an entire attack force of ours."

The construct seemed to find the slightest amusement in this. "I do not see how these could be a problem for you, unless you've grown soft over the millennia."

Unarin wanted to respond, but Mulgris continued. "The humans are putting up a decent fight though, in spite of my concerns. Clearly they had no warning about us, which fills me with disappointment. I had hoped there would be some sport in their extermination. If only you had told them everything you know about us, they might have been able to stop us."

For once, Unarin smiled. "You speak as if it is a foregone conclusion that you will win."

"Is it not?" Mulgris tapped a button on the display. "Three hundred of their one thousand initial ships are left. The others were torn to pieces."

"These are their scouting forces. They will undoubtedly lose many lives learning about the capabilities of the Sentinels, but don't you suppose it's possible they will adapt?"

"Of course. It will be too late by then, however." Mulgris waved a hand through the air. "Even if they had a Gatekeeper of their own, they lack a method to deploy it. They do not, of course, so they can't possibly hope to win." The construct paused for a moment. "Speaking of which, what happened to the old Gatekeeper?"

Unarin started to respond, but he was interrupted by his mechanical female assistant. "Executor, there is a broadcast being sent to our ship."

He raised an eyebrow. "I guess the humans are ready to ask some questions. Put it through."

A moment later, he was surprised to see not Jason Hiro or a human commander on the screen, but a different face.

"Satan. I distinctly remember the last time we saw each other." Unarin kept his expression tight, as he stared first at Satan, then at a female angel next to him. "Who is she?"

"You don't recognize me? Must be the wings." She held a strange tiny stick that was lit on fire, and occasionally she placed it to her lips and inhaled sharply before breathing out and exhaling smoke. "Marie. I made the anti-energy weapons you used for your Dragoons."

Mulgris immediately spoke up. "Dragoons? I thought those were outmoded trash heaps."

Unarin nodded. "They were, but since we didn't have the ability to use Sentinels..." His voice trailed off and the construct shifted slightly.

"That is a reasonable point."

Marie and Satan both appeared to be uninterested in the contents of the Volgrim's conversation, but Marie carefully studied the Sentinel leader, occasionally glancing at the female cyborg to the side.

"You don't appear to be a standard artificial intelligence. Your body seems to be efficiently constructed as well."

Mulgris ignored the compliment. "Why are you contacting us? We're busy launching an assault. Come to beg for your lives?"

"Yes. About that." Satan spoke slowly, keeping his face taut. "I am trying to come to a decision right now. Whether to aid the humans, the Volgrim, or stay neutral. I'm heavily leaning towards staying neutral. I had an agreement with the Volgrim, that they would kill the humans on Earth and leave the planet for us, but instead you destroyed Earth. That being said, as angry as I am about this act of treachery... I hold no love for humans."

Unarin immediately lowered his head. "I am not one to usually apologize, but the one who led the assault on Earth was not me. I have been out of contact with the united Volgrim forces for several of your Earthly decades, and Nufaris was the one you were in contact with. In addition to destroying Earth, he assassinated all of my brothers and sisters, the Volgrim Founders. I am sorry for how he deceived you."

Satan appeared to be taken aback at the apology. "Your words won't bring back Earth, but... I remember you now. Yes, we spoke several times in the past. I was told by Nufaris that you died during the destruction of your homeworld."

"I did not. I escaped through a portal to a... remote location. Specifically..." Unarin gestured at the construct just in front of him in the cramped cockpit. "...to release the Sentinels."

Marie chimed in again. "So they're called Sentinels? What sort of weapons are they?"

Mulgris raised a closed fist and held it straight up to silence Unarin from responding. "I care not who you are. Your assistance is unnecessary. If you interfere, you will be destroyed. If you stay out of the way, you will still be destroyed. Do what you please otherwise. You are insignificant."

Everyone stayed silent for a few moments, but only Unarin understood the truth behind those words. "Satan, you tricked me in Heaven and left me to die. In return, my subordinate double crossed you and went back on a deal the two of you made. As of now, I would say we are even. For your own good, I would advise against interfering in this battle. I would especially recommend hiding, for you will never be able to beat the Sentinels."

Marie smiled pleasantly. "Is that so? I don't like being threatened."

"It's not a threat, but a warning. You are misunderstanding something here. I do not control the Sentinels. Mulgris does. I have no power to stop them, any more than you, Jason Hiro, or the humans on the fourth planet do. I can promise you from experience that resisting the Sentinels will only lead to pain and torture."

Mulgris seemed to enjoy Unarin's speech. "The weak one is correct. However, if you choose to interfere, I will not lie... my people are dying for a challenge. Please do the best you can. This may be the last bit of fun we get to enjoy unless we find another sentient civilization to crush."

The other cyborg in the cockpit, Muuxunu, spoke up suddenly. "Might I advise leaving some survivors for a few thousand years so they can rise up to be crushed again?"

Mulgris turned and stared at her for a moment. "That, my dear, is an excellent idea."

Without any fanfare, the construct leaned forwards ever so slightly and deactivated the comm, cutting the feed instantly. "Enough idle chatter. I have been wanting to see more reports

of how the battle is going."

Unarin pressed a button on the wall as a flip-out chair popped out. Sitting down, he sighed. "I can't imagine you're having any trouble."

* * *

Echo and Storm stood beside a contingent of human infantry, awaiting their orders. In the sky above, humanity was fighting the Volgrim once again, and the two clones were the frontlines to protect Ursa Termina, the biggest major city on Mars. Everyone wore standard body armor except for the two clones, who wore their full hypersuits as always.

Echo raised his hand to his head, then made a chopping motion. "Three of the unknown bogeys made it past the frontlines. They're beelining right for Mars."

"Hm. We couldn't shoot them out of the air?" Storm's voice was even, but inwardly he felt somewhat nervous.

"Tried. Two of them are really small, so we couldn't hit them. The other was massive, but didn't seem to take any damage. Aren't you hearing all this?"

Storm shook his head. "I never bothered getting my earpiece fixed. I like the silence."

"No, you're just lazy." Echo snickered to himself.

"No... I just like the silence." Storm corrected the other clone and shook his head. "Original is lazy. I just enjoy not having to talk all the time."

"You're talking right now."

"Nobody likes a smartass, Echo."

The clones stared at each other through their masks, even as the men nearby wondered how they could bicker with one another during such a nerve-wracking time.

Finally, Echo broke away. "Whatever. Look sharp, we've got five minutes to contact."

"You think they're going to land here?"

Both clones looked up into the sky as Echo shrugged. "Maybe. There are several divisions surrounding Ursa's perimeter. If one of them gets hit, we'll go provide reinforcements."

Time passed, and everyone was starting to feel a little antsy. Every so often, Echo would connect to the main network and ask if the hostile targets had landed, but every time the answer was 'no'."

Finally, they saw something. High up in the sky, three burning streaks of fire came rushing down. Storm had barely started to speak up when the objects smashed into the ground a half mile away, blasting dirt and rock in every direction as massive craters were left over.

"Jesus! How fast were they going? Talk about a crash landing!"

Echo smiled as everyone stared at the craters in the distance. "Guess we managed to shoot them down. That was uneventful."

A few men and women nearby laughed nervously, as they felt relief the targets had been reduced to a crumpled mess all over the ground.

Only a few moments later did they realize something wasn't right. A humming began to fill the air, and from the craters, the smoke dissipated. Two figures emerged, their bodies looking somewhat humanlike, but covered in metal. They appeared to be androids, or cyborgs, or something else. Both of them had two legs, four arms, and five fingered hands.

As every human in the contingent raised their weapons, there was a lumbering sound as the biggest crater's dirt shifted slightly, and a massive hand reached over the edge. Pulling itself up, a titanic metal being stood up, towering fifty feet into the sky. Unlike the other two, the head on the big one was triangular, resembling a pyramid, and it spun around slowly as if scanning the area.

Echo and Storm froze for a solid two seconds, before Echo finally woke up. "Don't just stand there! Fire!"

The platoon of soldiers all took their designated cover positions and began unloading on the machines, blasting them with lasers, small armaments, and even anti-energy rifles... just in case.

Storm dashed forwards towards the two smaller robots, both of which stood perfectly still and stared forwards unblinkingly, as if waiting for something.

Before he could cover the distance with his Hypersuit's incredible speed enhancements, a movement faster than Storm could perceive shifted in front of him, and the massive automaton fired a single laser straight into his chest, smashing him backwards and slamming him into the ground, pulverizing the rocky Martian soil into dust.

It didn't injure him, but the sudden shock left him stunned. "What- what just...?"

The massive automaton shifted slightly and aimed its pyramid head at the contingent of humans, and a microscopically thin laser shot out and swept horizontally, moving so fast that Echo, still in the rear guard, barely even saw it happen.

A second later, the head of every human that had dared to stand up slid off their bodies and fell to the ground. What was left of their body followed soon after.

Echo felt his resolve crumble as he whispered into his microphone. "B-backup. Backup. We need... we need backup."

* * *

Kraal and Voltes had successfully landed on the planet, along with the assault type, Morphox. Immediately, the three of them began to communicate at one million times the speed the inferior biologicals could hope to achieve, by expelling high density waves of sound outwards. To the biologicals, they might feel a tingling in the air, but it was beyond their comprehension of how such advanced beings might communicate.

Scarcely had they reformed and shifted to their respective bipedal modes, than the biological contaminants moved in to attack.

Primitive era laser and shell-type weaponry flew at the Sentinels at astoundingly slow speeds.

Scanning for threat levels. Kraal toned blankly in a speed that could be described as nearly the speed of light.

Rapidly, they examined the armaments and defensive capabilities of the biologicals.

Primary attack unit threat status: Nonexistent.

Kraal sent his report out as Voltes scanned a single unit that had charged forwards. *Scan complete. Threat level of commander units: Nonexistent.*

The massive Morphox aimed his high impact stun beam at the biological charging towards them. *Mulgris wants one alive.*

Affirmative. Take that one.

Kraal gave the approval and Morphox sent the beam forwards, nearly killing the small creature with its accidental ferocity.

Still, all three Sentinels were surprised to read that the vital signs on the biological had not altered in the slightest. It struggled on the ground for a moment before managing to pull itself up.

Voltes spoke next. *Threat reassessment required. High impact stun beam was unable to disrupt vital functions. Armor is enhanced far beyond ordinary limits of the material.*

Confirmed. Threat level revised: Low. Eliminate the other biologicals. Take care to not damage this one.

Moving to eliminate. Morphox swiveled his head around and switched to his secondary attack, the Incision Laser.

A moment later, he gave a confirmation signal. *Forward defense group terminated. Ninety-three remain.*

Unit Kraal, I am detecting high levels of Type 3 energy in the commander units.

Noted. Move to engage. Remember, we are only here to scout their defenses. We must wait for the rest of our kind to arrive.

Morphox took one large step forwards. The native's defenses are primitive. We do not require assistance from the others.

Acknowledged. However, we have our orders.

Standing down. Morphox returned to his standing position even as the two biologicals shifted back to each other and appeared to be going on the defensive. *Continuing to observe.*

* * *

Echo's breathing was sharp, as he forced himself to ignore the carnage in the rear. "I didn't even see them move."

A moment later, several dozen other clones popped in at his location, all of them immediately looking around until they spotted the strange, motionless robots.

"We're here. This is all we could bring." One of the clones beckoned at the others in his group. "What are we up against? These fuckers are damn near invincible in space."

"Not sure. They hit me with... something. Wiped out half the platoon in the next instant. It happened so fast."

Echo strode forwards. "We don't have time to waste. They're just standing there, but if they move to attack the city, we'll have a second Christmas Day Massacre on our hands. Whatever these robots are, they're monsters. Storm, have you Wordsmithed at them yet?"

"No."

"I'll try it now. **EXPLOSION!** "

A massive blast erupted right at the spot where one of the robots stood, and the fire from the blast swept outwards for almost two hundred feet before dissipating into smoke. A moment later, the smoke cleared and still the robot stood, staring straight at them.

"Great job, Echo."

"Piss off. At least I tried."

"Right. Now my turn." Storm quickly turned to eyeball the bigger robot warily. He didn't want to be hit by that blast a second time, even if the damage *was* negligible. " **Speed! Perception!** "

Time slowed to a tenth of normal speed around him as he breathed evenly. If the robots sent out another one of those attacks, he'd be able to see them coming.

He dashed forwards once more, again using the enhanced abilities the suit gave him to move much faster than would ordinarily be possible. "Centurion, activate Lightning Mode!"

"LIGHTNING MODE IS NOW IN EFFECT. MOVEMENT SPEED HAS BEEN INCREASED BY 500%, PILOT JASON HIRO!"

"God, I hate that name." Storm half-dashed, half-teleported here and there as he shifted from one spot to another, and in just a few seconds, he raised his fist back to punch at one of the smaller two robots.

Then their heads swiveled to look at him, as if he wasn't moving fast even in the slightest.

Storm's blood ran cold.

The robot he was about to punch swung its own arm out at a frightening speed, far exceeding what even he was capable of reacting to in his current state. Still, Centurion compensated, nearly breaking his back as it forced him to duck and avoid the horizontal swipe.

He jerked back up and jumped backwards, but the robot merely stared at him silently... as if it were simply learning his attack patterns.

He didn't hesitate, even though his back hurt a little now. " **Speed! Speed! Perception! Perception!** "

His energy began to drain much faster, but now the world was moving at close to a thousandth its normal speed. He dashed forwards and swung at the machine, connecting with his hypersuit enhanced fist and punching the machine with all his might.

The machine stood perfectly still, and the armor on it showed no signs of damage. It was as if he hadn't punched it at all.

He pulled his fist back and stared at it in horror. "What... what the hell?" Storm stared into the eyes of the automaton and it stared back silently, as if waiting for something.

For a brief second, Storm thought he felt an odd humming sensation from all three machines at once.

Then the robot vanished. It moved far faster than his eye could track, darting somewhere to his side and delivering a flurry of blows that sent him rolling to the side. It was on him in a second, grabbing him by the leg and swinging him over its shoulder, and plowing him into the ground with brutal force.

Storm gasped as the wind was knocked out of him, but he barely had an instant to realize what happened. The robot swung him again, this time hurling him back at his companions, where he flew through the air and smashed into an embankment right at their feet.

Storm stared forwards silently as his head swam. He couldn't think straight. He couldn't see properly. Spots danced in his vision while he tried to understand what had just happened.

When a few seconds had passed, he shook the feeling off and spoke again. " **Normalize.** "

His energy finally stopped dropping as he returned to normal time. Already, the other clones were just beginning to realize he was at their feet. "Storm! What just happened?"

He climbed to his feet and stood shakily. "I... I don't know. I don't know."

Just as the barrage of questions started, the ground began to tremble. Everyone looked over at the massive robot, just in time for one of its eyes to light up.

"Oh... fuck."

* * *

Far away, on a ridge nearly a mile tall, two figures watched the battle erupting among the humans and scouting robots, apprehension filling both of them. Despite the distance, the smaller of the two could see what was going on clearly, using her keen eyesight to track things as they happened.

"This must be the flashpoint. How do we stop it?"

The tall one shook his head. "I am unsure, my lady. Both of us lack the power to defeat them."

The woman gripped the holy sword at her side tightly, as her blonde hair flapped in the wind. "I could try to use this."

"You lack the ability to use it properly. We must make sure that Jason Hiro receives it. It should be considered his, after all."

"Maybe. But we've seen what happens when he goes wild with it. It's too dangerous. I took it for a reason."

"Earth was destroyed anyway. Whether he did it, or the Volgrim did it, or Satan did it... it was going to happen. You can't blame him for an event that he didn't propagate."

She shook her head slowly. "I can and I will. I'm not just going to give him Excalibur. He's likely to destroy Mars too."

The tall being placed his massive green hand on her shoulder. "You must learn to forgive him. Your uncle's death was not his fault. In fact, you saw him crying at the funeral."

"Fake tears. Crying won't bring my uncle back. I remember when he plunged the knife into my uncle's heart."

"That was a different time, a different life. The Jason of this stream knows nothing of the events you are referring to, and he is thus guiltless. We can move to another stream, one where your uncle is surely still alive and Earth still exists in another. Why not consider it? Why not make a new beginning for yourself?"

"Those streams wouldn't be *my* stream, Grok. Those belong to other versions of me. Hell, I don't even exist in some of them. The man in those streams would not be my uncle, he wouldn't even know who I was."

Grok lowered his hand and sighed. "Yet... here I am."

The woman lowered her head. "You know what I meant."

"I do, but I just don't agree. Come on, Daisy, let's keep looking. An opportunity is sure to present itself."

"We'll see."

The girl reached up and held the orc's hand, smiling in spite of the dark depression inside of herself. A moment later, the two of them vanished in a flash of light.

Part 378a: The Lost Ones

How is this possible? The reports coming in from the ground forces indicate that a few of the enemies we're fighting in space crash-landed at ridiculous speeds yet were not damaged, wiped out a platoon of human soldiers in just a few seconds, and then proceeded to embarrass my clone fighting forces. Only three of these weird Volgrim robots arrived on Mars, but apparently my clones are having a hell of a time dealing with them.

Things aren't going any better in space.

"We can't lock on to their forms anymore!" Sensei's face is beet red with rage. "How are these monsters so unstoppable?! They're peeling our forces apart like wet paper!"

"How could they possibly be preventing a lock-on?" I ask the question and then remember I don't know how most technology works. I have no fundamental grasp of the physics involved since I usually just cheat and use the Crown.

"That's the thing; I don't know! They just seem to shift their forms rapidly, and now our weapons can't assume an automatic lock. We've been targeting them manually, and that's going about as well as you'd expect." Sensei squeezes his eyes shut and rubs his forehead. "We've never taken losses like this before. They have a 100% win ratio so far. If this keeps up we'll be lucky to flee and save the species."

Something about this feels so wrong to me. "If the Volgrim had these unstoppable juggernauts the whole time, why did Unarin wait until now to deploy them?"

Sensei shakes his head slowly. "I don't know. Maybe the reason he wasn't there for the Earth assault was because he was working on these monstrosities. He allowed Nufaris to lead the attack so that he could stay and develop these."

I start to respond, but Sensei interrupts me. "No, wait. That doesn't make sense either. Why even bother with destroying Earth? They were under no time constraints. We weren't bearing down on them anytime soon. He could have just held off for a couple of years and attacked us once our exploration ships arrived in his space."

"Perhaps he assumed Refuge was indestructible. If he did, then it would make sense for a being who thinks he's part of the chosen species to attempt a total annihilation of our kind. He possibly might have thought that we had no chance of stopping a super-weapon twice the size of the Moon since he nullified my Wordsmithing."

"No, it still wouldn't make sense. Unarin is overconfident and proud, but he's also much more cautious now. We've defeated him so many times there isn't a chance that he'd underestimate us."

Our ship is suddenly rocked by an explosion and both of us stumble backward and fall on our asses. We pull ourselves back up and look at a report. The Sentinels hit the engineering bay, but it wasn't serious. My clones are already repairing it with Wordsmithing.

Sensei grits his teeth. "We're missing pieces of the puzzle. Where is Nufaris during all of this? He led the strike force that destroyed Earth, and we definitely didn't kill him. Unarin was nowhere to be seen, yet he appeared out of nowhere with a massive robot army." Sensei shrugs and corrects himself. "Well, a small robot army that fights like a large one anyway. There are only fifty thousand enemy combatants. We have millions of well-trained soldiers."

"You know what they say about size not mattering. If we can't find a way to beat the Volgrim, we're dead in the water, and we've lost a lot of lives for no reason."

Sensei sighs and closes his helmet to look at some information on his HUD. "I can't accomplish anything here. I'm going to Termina Ursa to help on the frontlines. If you think of anything, let me know."

"Will do. Stay safe."

Sensei stares at me for a few moments before Harold receives his mental request and teleports him away.

Now I'm standing alone on the Mothership's bridge, wondering what I should do next. We're facing a threat unlike any before it; a foe that seems to be immune to all forms of damage, one that can change its shape, and moves at ungodly speeds compared to us. If we can't figure out something, we're going to all die.

Noticing Sensei has left, a clone across the bridge speaks up. "Unarin is still refusing to respond to our hails."

"Keep trying. We have to come up with a counter, and any hint would be useful here."

An idea comes to mind. I send a telepathic message to Sensei. *Try getting creative with wordsmithing. Teleport them to the center of the planet. I'll keep thinking of what to do.*

Sensei barely gives me an affirmation. While I stand alone, tapping my chin, one of the nearby clones on the bridge of the Mothership turns to look at me. "You know, we don't have to do guesswork here. There's one person who might know what these robots are."

"Who?" I stare at him quizzically, and he looks at me in disbelief.

"You don't remember? Dosea! We captured her during the war in Heaven decades ago. If anyone is going to know what these things are, she will."

"Oh. I had forgotten about her." I stare at my clone blankly, and he shakes his head at me in response. Silently, he turns back to his station and I can't help but feel like if he were looking at me, he'd be glaring in disapproval.

Sometimes I feel like there's a fog over my mind. It's like something is actively trying to prevent me from advancing past my personal limitations. For a man with godlike powers, there are times when I feel so... insignificant.

Still, I thank my clone mentally. At least I can still rely on them. All it takes is a single word, and I'll be one step closer to getting the answers I need.

"Teleport. "

* * *

I arrive in Dimension V, as I used to call it, and am immediately surprised. The world was once barren, and all the food had to be wordsmithed by the clone I put on permanent duty here, but it looks like his laziness got the better of him and he made the planet self-sufficient. Of course, 'planet' is a strong word, considering the world here exists outside the boundaries of the ordinary universe, no stars are in the sky, and the whole thing is smaller than the asteroid I used to destroy Volgarius itself.

Oh... right. I never told Dosea about that. In fact, I ordered my clone not to mention it. I figured that it would make her sad and considering the lack of hostilities between us, there was no need for that.

My clone isn't here now, but I arrive smack in the center of the city's square, and everyone notices me immediately. I'm quickly taken aback by how everyone is dressed. It's as if I stepped into the center of Rome from two millennia ago. Everyone is wearing white robes, the female Volgrim are wearing something almost satin-like, and the material is somewhat see-through. Their bodies are very sexualized, but any thought I have involving questionable conduct is of course tempered by the mouthfuls of shark-like teeth they have.

Still, I never thought of the Volgrim as being anything but stuffy, uptight robots. To see them like this is jarring, to say the least.

A male Volgrim walks up to me. "Greetings. You share the same face as Pickle, yet your demeanor is more cautious. I presume you must be a different clone. I am Sirin."

I immediately scrunch up my face. "Pickle? Is... is that really the name of the clone I stationed here? I thought he called himself Demitri."

Sirin stares at me like I am an idiot. "He informed us that Pickle was a name that meant 'one of great honor' in the human tongue. Is that incorrect?"

"No, that's correct. Totally. I just... uh... didn't know he changed his name." I feel my brain pulse slightly. At least the clone stationed here is having fun when he's not fighting on the battlefield. "Ignoring 'Pickle', I'm the original, not a clone. I need to speak with Dosena."

His eyes light up. "She will be most pleased that you have come! Follow me and I will take you to her castle."

Her castle?

My head hurts. Dosena is living like royalty? But why? Well, I suppose that will be answered in due time. She was previously the second highest Volgrim among her kind, so I can understand why she would wish to live like a queen. Seems kind of conceited though.

As we walk down the road towards the large castle in the distance, Sirin gestures here and there towards various people and things. "It has been many cycles since we last saw you. In fact, after our internment here, you never returned. I think you should find it interesting how we have progressed since you were last here."

Not really. That sounds awful, and I'm in a rush.

I want to say that, but he seems like such a nice guy. "Sure."

There is no hesitation. "I manage this city, which is our only place of living anywhere on Voldarius. Due to the complete lack of metal on this planet, we have had to improvise to improve our way of life. The lack of seasons makes growing food simple, since it is always the perfect temperature everywhere. The star you created, while small, is quite energetic."

I simply nod along, pretending to listen. "Very interesting." A thought occurs to me, however. "Hold on, I thought the Volgrim didn't need to eat food? Aren't you guys mostly robotic?"

Sirin whistles pleasantly. "You are correct. Under normal circumstances, we would not require such primitive substances. We mutated our bodies over millions of years to run mostly off of electrical impulses, provided to us by complex machinery." He turns his head back to me, smiling, but I can't help noticing there is a pang of sadness in his eyes. "Of course, machinery and electronics are banned due to our status as prisoners of war, so we must rely on the old ways to survive. Even we are only immortal so long as we have energy to consume."

I feel a sudden stab of guilt as he turns back forward. I want to say something, but he lifts his voice. "Ah, we are in luck. One of the wooden taxis is here." He barely lifts a hand, and the

driver starts cranking some strange wheel, grunting as he does to make the vehicle move. It reminds me mechanically of a bicycle, and it's powered entirely due to his own physical energy.

"Actually, that won't be necessary, Sirin. I'm in a rush to speak with her, so I'll just speed us along." I lightly put my hand on his shoulder, and a moment later, I teleport us the remaining mile to Dosena's castle. On arrival, Sirin's peaceful facade seems to crack as he stumbles forward to the ground, coughing and sputtering.

Sometimes I forget that teleportation can be jarring the first time someone does it. "Sorry, I teleported us and forgot to warn you."

"N-no, it's fine." He stands back up and wipes at his mouth. "I was simply startled. I did not know such forms of travel were possible other than through portals."

He waves me forwards, and less than a minute later, we stand in front of a large wooden door. The castle itself is made of stone, but like everywhere else I've seen, no metal is visible. Of course, I know exactly why. I had ordered 'Pickle' to never make metal or electronic objects for fear these Volgrim could escape and reunite with their people. Now, however, I am having second thoughts. This feels like cruel imprisonment.

We walk in her main room and I'm surprised to see Dosena leaning heavily on the table with her head resting on her palm, while she plays a strange board game with another female Volgrim, a game I've never seen before. The pieces are intricately hand-cut, and the board resembles a weird multi-stage chessboard. Whatever the game is, I'm sure Amelia would love it.

"Founder Dosena, you have a visitor." Sirin bows slightly as she slowly turns her head to look at me. It appears to take several seconds for her to recognize me. "Oh. You."

Compared with the impeccable politeness of Sirin, Dosena fills her greeting with boredom and the impression she couldn't care less about my arrival. She barely even looks at me after saying hello before returning to her game.

Sirin shoots a strange look at me and shrugs as he quickly walks out of the room. I slowly walk up to Dosena and the other woman, wondering how the hell I'm going to broach the subject.

"I thought I told you not to bother me." Dosena's voice is heavy and drags along as she speaks.

"I... don't remember that at all."

"I yelled at you pretty loudly. I'm surprised you can't remember. You're dumber than I thought." She glances over at the other Volgrim girl, and both of them seem to share a look of knowing, as if there's a private communication I'm missing.

Ah, that's right, the Volgrim have telepathy, and Dosena is an especially powerful telepath.

"You might have me confused with someone else. I'm not the clone that's usually here... 'Pickle'. I'm Jason. The original one."

A strange transformation occurs as she quickly looks at me and scans me up and down, as a sudden interest appears in her eyes. "I haven't seen you in decades, human. Had you merely forgotten about us? Did we serve our purpose here as useful pawns for bargaining against Unarin?"

Her words sting. This wasn't the reaction Sirin prepared me to expect. "Uh... no. Nothing like that. I didn't forget, I was just... busy."

Her eyes narrow. "I cannot read your mind, but I can perceive many things by the tone of your voice, the sweat collecting on your forehead, and a variety of other indicators. You're lying. You didn't keep your word." She sits up straight at the table and seems to have lost all interest in the game.

"Fine. You got me. The war against the demons and Volgrim has been long fought. We're finally-" I pause, realizing I'm probably saying too much. "Well, let's just say that I need your help."

Dosena stares blankly at me for several moments before shaking her head and staring at the other Volgrim across from her. "He wants my help."

"He wants your help." The other parrots the words back at her, and both of them act like it's the craziest thing in the world.

"Listen, I see why you're mad. Really, I do. I don't blame you. Still, it was Unarin who tossed you to the side and left you to die. I allowed you to live on this planet and gave you a clone to make sure you lived in relative comfort."

"Comfort." She mumbles the word and deftly reaches over to move a piece on the board. She seems to have half turned her attention back to the game. "I have not seen any of those I call friends in thousands of planetary cycles. In fact, I don't even know exactly how long it's been. This planet doesn't rotate, and we have no reliable methods for keeping track of time. I have long since forgiven Unarin for his actions." The other female moves a piece on the board and Dosena responds immediately with her own counter.

"That's fair. Still, I won't leave until I get an answer. Unarin has deployed... these... *things*. Strange robots that are destroying humanity's military might. We can't hurt them at all. They appear to be unstoppable."

For a few long moments, Dosena stares at the board, contemplating something unseen.

Finally, she speaks. "You destroyed Volgarius."

I feel my eyes twitch. "Why do you think that?"

"The Sentinels. There... there's no chance he would ever risk activating them. We lost trillions of lives to them. He'd never do it. Never. Not a remote possibility."

Dosena lowers her head, and her voice tightens. "You must have destroyed Volgarius. The Volgrim must be on the verge of extinction. It's the only possibility. Unarin would never... he would never..."

Her sudden rush of emotion makes me take a step back. "Sentinels, huh? What are they? You look terrified."

"I am." Dosena raised her head up, and I'm surprised to see a tear streak down her face. "You don't understand. You won't be able to get it. They can't be defeated."

The female across from her notices the tears. "Founder? Are you in need of emotional assistance?"

Dosena wipes at her eyes and pulls her gaze from mine to stare at the ground. "That isn't necessary. There's no hope left. We already used the Gatekeeper protocol. The same trick won't work twice on them... they always adapt to anything we use. We have no more counters left."

"The Gatekeeper protocol? What's that?" I feel my interest piqued, despite her insistence that whatever it is won't work.

"The Sentinels are a highly advanced army made of artificial intelligences. However, in order to make them, we used the minds of brilliant military leaders. The goal was to create a fighting force that would be powerful enough to pacify both sides of the civil war and force a diplomatic treaty. The problem... the problem came when..." Her voice trailed off for a moment as memories seemed to return. "...they were too powerful. The AI began to corrupt the philosophies we installed so as to pursue more hedonistic pleasures. They began to see the Volgrim as a threat. Despite all of our preparation, they disabled the kill switches we installed and began to adapt their forms to improve their combat skills. Soon, they gained the ability to shift their appearance for a variety of combat situations, and their weaponry far outstripped even our own."

Her eyes are hollow now. "You can't destroy them. We sacrificed a million Volgrim lives in the blink of an eye to create a newer, more powerful intelligence. It had the sole purpose of defeating them... but it didn't succeed."

I raise an eyebrow. "It didn't? But I thought you said-"

"I did. As I said before, they cannot be defeated. All we managed to do was disable them. The Gatekeeper's role was to use its superior processing power to keep all of the Sentinels shut down. Their bodies were made of materials we could scarcely dent by that point, even with our most powerful weaponry. We couldn't destroy them entirely."

I suck in a breath slowly. "So you sealed them away, and Unarin has awoken them."

Dosena surprises me again by smiling widely. "Yes! That's all there is to it! Unarin has realized there is no hope of defeating humanity, but as a final curse upon your name, he has awoken the terror that finally put an end to the Great Wars of Volgrim myth." Dosena chuckled as she lightly flicked over a piece on the board. "We lose, but so do you. You're doomed now."

Her attitude pisses me off, not that I can mentally blame her for her feelings, but emotionally her love of death just drives me up the wall.

"We'll see about that. I will think of a way to defeat them."

She smiles at me with a mocking expression. "Best get to it, then, Jason. They can process information at a trillion times the speed your mind could ever comprehend, and you're already only half as fast as the rest of humankind. Your disadvantage couldn't be more clear."

I glare at her silently for a few moments. "I won't lose. Enjoy your stay here, Dosena. I see I made the right choice."

"Whatever allows you to sleep at night." She turns away to look at the board again. "Begone, now."

"Teleport. "

She can laugh if she wants. I won't let the metal monsters put an end to my species.

* * *

I arrive back at the mothership and suppress my rage. I can't honestly blame Dosena. She has every reason to hate me. I killed her people and forced her to live in exile on a planet that offers her very little mental stimulation.

Still, I feel angry at her. It's irrational, and I know it, but I can't help it. Her kind created these metal monsters, but now mine must suffer.

Sensei. I've just learned some key information about the robots you're fighting. I send a mental communication to him and wait a few moments.

He responds, but his mental voice is strained and stressed. I was only away for about half an hour, but it sounds like he's been fighting for days. *Great! Show me what you've got! These*

fuckers can't be teleported, and that inverted energy surrounds all three of them. The same stuff that surrounded the Moon and the space station. It's impossible to get past!

Impossible, huh? That word can't exist to me. There has to be a way. Anything is possible if I put my mind to it.

I quickly explain to him what I've learned, and he listens intently. Every so often, I feel a perception of pain, but I ignore it until I'm done explaining.

Hyper-adaptive death robots that nearly exterminated the Volgrim. Fantastic! I couldn't ask for a more hilariously overpowered foe! How do we stop them?

I cringe at the question. *I don't know. Still working on it. Try just immobilizing them if you can. I'll keep working on a solution.*

Great! Can't wait! Hope we don't all die in the meantime! I feel the signal cut off abruptly and wonder what the hell is going on down there.

I quickly walk off the bridge. "I'll be back. If you need me, send word."

"Sure thing, Original." One of my clones barely nods at me.

Something about the way my clones treat me... they openly call me stupid. They treat me as an inferior. I have more magical energy than them, but if I can't use it properly, what good is it?

I locate Amelia with my mind. Perhaps she can help me. Leviathan is supposed to be powerful, maybe he can think of something.

I pause while walking down the hallway. Come to think of it, if it's knowledge and ingenuity I need, maybe there's another solution here. There might be someone else who can help.

"Umi. Are you there?"

It doesn't take a second for her to respond. "Yes, Jason Hiro. I am always watching."

Creepy fucker. "Umi, did you listen to my conversation with Dosena?"

"Naturally. Of course, it was all information I already knew, but it was still a conversation I logged for archival purposes."

"Great. Tell me, is there a way I can defeat an enemy that is invulnerable to conventional weaponry, enhanced weaponry, magical energy, and everything else we've tried up to now? Is there a way I can defeat the Sentinels?"

Umi chirps softly. "Not to my knowledge, Jason Hiro. In fact, once I realized the Sentinels were going to put an end to all sentient species, I attempted to prevent Unarin from enabling their primary processors. However, they had already adapted to the Gatekeeper protocol, and thus I was unable to stop them."

The news is shocking. "You... couldn't... even stop them?"

"Correct."

Several seconds pass as fear washes over me. This is serious. Umi once told me she could put an end to all sentient life in seconds, just as she killed thousands of Volgrim aboard a ship I had captured. I believed her. No, I *still* believe her. She is a frightening existence, one that can destroy all life as we know it and it wouldn't even bother her. Our only defense is that she likes to watch us play around with our little guns and stuff.

Shit.

If she can't stop them, what can I do? As expected, that inverted energy field has become a real nuisance. I simply can't get past it. It renders my powers inoperable.

Except... wait. Does it really? No. Despite a field billions of times stronger than the one that surrounds the Sentinels, Arthur managed to destroy Refuge somehow. He blasted straight through the Moon as if it didn't even exist. How did he do that?

"Umi, do you know how Arthur managed to destroy Refuge?"

"I do. He blasted Refuge with energy that exceeded the field's ability to compensate, resulting in an overload of all its power cells and its eventual destruction."

"So could the same thing work against the Sentinels?"

"Possibly. However, you lack the energy to perform such a feat. The energy required is neither diminished nor increased based on the size and intensity of the inverse energy field."

Damn. Another roadblock. "What if I took the energy from all of my clones? Would that be enough?"

"Negative. Even if all of your clones were fully rested and their energy were full, Arthur's energy level was several orders of magnitude greater than your combined powers."

Jesus Christ. I knew he was strong, but that's mindblowing. Was Arthur even exaggerating when he said he was the most powerful Hero to have ever lived?

I stare at the floor in front of me thoughtfully. Amelia comes walking around the corner at that moment and spots me. "Jason! How is the battle going?"

I ignore her and continue staring downwards. There has to be an answer. There must be a way to obtain energy of that magnitude. Perhaps Leviathan? No, that risks injuring Amelia. I can't take a chance like that.

"Hellooooo! Jason! Mars to Jason!" Amelia waves her hand in front of my face, and I raise my head up to look at her.

"Umi, can I convert energy from one type to another with Wordsmithing?"

Amelia crinkles up her nose. "Uh, my name isn't Umi. Umi is the computer girl..."

Umi immediately responds to my question. "Unknown. However, it is certainly within the possible scope of your ability."

"Ah. I see. Thank you." I smile pleasantly at Amelia now. "I'll be right back. I need to try and kill two birds with one stone."

"Huh?" Amelia looks totally confused, but I don't have time to explain. People are dying every second.

"Be right back." My visor closes, and I mentally check my hypersuit for airtightness. "**Return.**"

* * *

A moment later, Amelia is gone, and I am floating in a familiar, yet alien black void. As expected, Hawkeye did what he was ordered. He placed a waypoint in the system for Revival.

The planet Revival is too far for me to see. It might be on the other side of the system's star... but, I guess it doesn't matter. The Volgrim already took it over. Humanity won't be able to use it now. The least I can do is deprive them of its resources for the war efforts.

My suit gives off an alarm as several blips come towards me on the scanner. Enemy ships, or maybe some stragglers from the Sentinels. Both mean serious business, so I can't afford to dawdle.

Quickly, I stare directly at the system's star. My hypersuit protects me from eye damage as it darkens. "**Teleport.**"

I arrive directly in front of the star. I'm thousands of miles away, and the Hypersuit protects me from its incredible heat and brightness, but still, the scale is awe inspiring. I've never seen anything like this in my life. I had a star available, but I never thought to get this close to one.

It's... beautiful.

And it needs to die.

I reach my hand out. "**ABSORB!**"

Several moments later, my mind screams in pain. I feel a rush of adrenaline as every blood vessel in my body feels like they're about to burst. And then the light from the star stops. The star vanishes.

PAIN.

PAIN.

EVERYTHING HURTS.

IT BURNS.

I can't cope. My mind is going blank. " **Tuhlupurt.** "

I mumble a word half-heartedly and vanish away. I'm getting tired now, I just need to sleep and recuperate.

I just need to rest my eyes a moment.

Part 379a:

Kraal watched as the last fireball streaked across the sky and crashed into the ground. As soon as he detected his fellow unit had reformed itself he sent the signal outwards.

All Sentinels have landed. I have reset the score. The one who kills the most organics will be the next scouting leader. Commence attack now.

His signal transmitted all around himself in a vibration that could only be felt by the inferior fleshy humans as a humming sound. The other Sentinels repeated his message until it had passed around the entire planet, the entire transmission taking less than a second.

As soon as the others began their total extermination, Kraal and his two companions sent a signal of confidence to one another. *We have the advantage. We have already processed the organics' weaknesses.*

The massive Morphox took a long step forwards and several of the white-suited commander units jumped backward in kind. *How many points are the commander units worth compared to the low tier units?*

Civilians are one point. Military units are two. Structures are three. The commander units are ten.

A human commander unit aimed his hand at Kraal, and a strange metallic rope formed around the Sentinel, suddenly tightening and binding him in place. Kraal immediately directed his sensory units at the human and focused on him.

I have located my first victim. Switching to microscopic particle cannon.

One of Kraal's eye's shifted appearance slightly as it glowed for a moment. A laser shot out of the socket, piercing right through the commander unit's tough armor, and spinning in a circle around the pulmonary center of his body. A few milliseconds later, the armor fell apart in the front and the back as the commander faltered and fell to the ground. A crimson substance flowed out of his body and spilled all over the dirt, even as Kraal detected with his X-ray scanners that the damage was already being repaired to the commander's internal organs.

Revision required. I was able to pierce the armor by attacking at the microscopic level, but the commander units have high regenerative capabilities. Threat level revised: Medium. Commander units are now worth fifteen points. Kraal sent the signal out and received unanimous confirmation in response.

Voltes offered a helpful suggestion. *Unarin's data logs indicate the commander units are weak to the newly acquired neutralization energy. Suggestion: Weaken them with this energy, then pierce the armor with the particle cannon. In this way, they will not be able to heal.*

Noted. You weaken, I will kill.

Unacceptable. You will receive more points than me.

Confirmed. Alteration: We will split the points eight to seven.

Acknowledged, Unit Kraal. That is a satisfactory arrangement.

The two Sentinels turned and walked towards the human defensive perimeter, even as all the humans' body reactions shifted to extreme alarm and most of them radiated pheromones indicative of a primitive fearful reaction.

Two commander units ran forwards and aimed their hands at the robots. Kraal watched silently as a wall of steel suddenly shot up out of the ground, blocking them from moving forward.

Organic commander units have the ability to create level one barriers. Their abilities defy the laws of physics.

Voltes hummed to the other Sentinels in the area and they all sent the confirmation signals. *Acknowledged. Barrier is made of soft elements. It will not slow us down.*

The massive Morphox took three huge steps, moving at an ungodly speed for his size, and in the next second, his arm raced forwards and pulverized the wall with a single punch. *Stop relying on this unit for everything. These humans are insignificant compared to the Volgrim.*

Kraal continued walking forward, waiting for Voltes to send out the neutralization energy beams before using his laser to cut out the hearts of the humans before them. One by one, the humans and their commander units began to die at satisfying speeds.

This is tedious. The scientists at Melkia put up a better fight.

Voltes hummed to himself in annoyance, and Kraal echoed his thoughts. *Agreed. Being shut down for millions of cycles apparently did nothing to increase the threat level of the galaxy. A shame.*

Perhaps after we exterminate the organics, we should create a new breed purely for combat purposes? That would be an entertaining endeavor. The two of them continued tearing down all who stood before them, even as they shared a tone of sadness.

A commander unit ran up and tossed a small device at the two robots. Kraal evaluated its warfare capabilities in an instant. *Electromagnetic grenade. Projected damage levels:*

Insignificant.

The grenade went off, causing no damage to the two of them as they tore the commander unit to ribbons, sending out a reminder to other Sentinels to ignore such devices in the future.

I wish they had kept me shut down for another million cycles. This is disheartening. Kraal intoned to himself as the Sentinels continued their unstoppable onslaught.

* * *

"Sensei! They can pierce through the Hypersuits now!" Echo's voice was frantic. "They can even suppress our healing! What do we do?!"

Sensei kept his voice neutral. "C-calm down, Echo. We just need to buy time. We're evacuating the civilians to Heaven. We've long since cleared away the bodies of the angels, so they won't know what Heaven used to be. These robots shouldn't be able to follow us to the other dimensions. For now, just keep drawing their attention. Original will be back soon!"

"He's been gone for hours! We can't hold off fifty thousand of these rob-" Echo stopped speaking abruptly, as his hand shot upwards towards his neck and stopped in midair. A moment later, his head fell from his body as his corpse flopped to the ground. A wave of anti-energy swept over the command post as the Sentinels arrived outside without warning.

Jesus! They're fast! Sensei didn't focus long on Echo. He was a brother, a friend, but a clone nonetheless. More could be made if necessary. This included Sensei himself of course, but still, he couldn't let sentimentality get in their way. They were all likely to die waiting while Original did... whatever the hell he was doing.

Gods, Original sounded like he was on the verge of something big. I hope he can figure something out.

A voice crackled over his hypersuit's communicator as he fled away from the forward base. It erupted into fire behind him after the Sentinels tore through it. "Sensei! You're one of Jason's top clones, correct?"

The voice was immediately familiar. "Commander Beatrix! I am, what's going on?"

"I'm sending reinforcements your way. Prototypes. These are a new robot called the Alpha Guard. We based them off the micro-dreadnoughts. They're much smaller and nimbler. They won't be able to do much against these Sentinels, but they might be able to cut human casualties down a bit."

"How many can you send?"

Her reply was breathless. "Five hundred thousand. We're pushing the fabricators to the max. We might get a thousand more out by day's end if we live that long."

"That's not nearly enough! Even ten-to-one, the Sentinels will cut them down!" Sensei muted the comm for a moment as he wordsmithed. " **Wings!** "

Angelic wings sprouted, shooting out through the back of his suit and allowing him to take to the air as he left the forward guard behind. "Beatrix, how many citizens of Mars have managed to evacuate?"

"About fifteen percent. We have several portals constructed, but there are millions of people! It would take several days to save everyone under circumstances we could prepare for!"

"I don't want excuses. If the Volgrim break into Termina Ursa... destroy the portals. I'd rather save half of humanity than none of it."

"You're confident they can't follow after the refugees into Heaven?"

"I'm not even remotely sure of that. We might get lucky, but so far the only capabilities they've shown is immense warmongering potential. Just keep at it!" Sensei cut the comm line and turned back to stare at the landscape below him.

This high up, he could barely hear the sound of the devastation below. An explosion sounded off as a human tossed a grenade at one of the Sentinels in a final act of futility before his entire body was melted down by an unseen beam.

Their reaction times are so much faster than ours. It's as if they perceive the universe on a level more advanced than us. To them, we are slugs trying to use slime as a deadly weapon. It won't work. Original was right, this level of destruction can't simply come from nowhere. The Volgrim played with fire, and now we're the ones being burned.

Sensei shot a look up into outer space. Somewhere up there, Unarin was watching, safe inside his vessel. He was probably smiling as he gloated about how the humans were being wiped out.

Bastard.

Sensei flew over towards another ridge where clones were being mowed down by a dozen of the death-bots.

"Centurion, alert me when Original returns to the battlefield. I need to speak with him at once."

"REMINDER SET, PILOT JASON HIRO."

The AI sent its affirmation, and Sensei glowered at the inside of the suit. "That isn't my goddamn name."

* * *

Satan stood beside an angel and a human, as both versions of Marie watched the monitor silently. The ferocity and emotionless violence of the robots didn't affect them, nor did the level of death, but still, all three felt ice in their veins.

"Those things will come for us next." The human spoke quietly, her voice barely a whisper. "I've taken it upon myself as a challenge to think of a way to beat them... but after hearing what happened to the universe of C137... I don't want to do anything desperate yet."

The angel glanced over at her human counterpart. "What happened to it?"

"It's the only other universe the Sentinels appeared. Jason destroyed the entire universe by accident."

Now Satan was flabbergasted. "You're kidding! I know wordsmithing is powerful, but how could he have possibly done such a thing?"

"He used 'Singularity' and accidentally let it get out of control. Idiot."

"Oh." Satan waited, but no explanation was forthcoming. "What's a singularity?"

"It's a human science thing."

"Ah, I see. I don't care then." Satan turned back to the screen just in time to wince as another clone was cut down by three Sentinels at the same time. "If this keeps up, I won't be able to get revenge on him for destroying my people. I can't just let these mechanical nightmares take over everything!"

"You'd better stay out of it, Satan dearest. I don't think you know what you're dealing with." The human Marie walked away and over to a large rectangular glass tank, where several little lizards slithered around inside. She pressed a button, and several flies were deposited inside, causing the lizards to frenzy after the fresh supply of food.

"I have no clue indeed. Humans and Volgrim... your species lack the power needed to rule, so you create artificial constructs to fight your wars for you. Cowardly, if you ask me. Crushing the skull of an opponent is the most satisfying way to win a battle."

"Yes, but our 'cowardly ways' also allow us to win." The angel glanced at the screen just in time to see a clone's head sliced in half. "Most of the time."

"It isn't doing you any favors now. The Volgrim's constructs turned on them, as they have attacked the humans. Soon, they will be at our doorstep." He scratched his chin thoughtfully. "Forget this. I can't stay here any longer. I'm going out there."

"It's your funeral." The angel had hardly spoken the words before Satan vanished with a quick movement of his hands.

She stared at the spot where he had been standing for a few moments before turning to look at her human counterpart. "Would you stop playing with the damn lizards? Help me find a way to stop the Sentinels!"

"I will, so calm your horses. I can't help it if my cuties are hungry." She leaned over and cooed softly at the little creatures running around in the glass before turning back to the angel. "Let's see what we can do."

Part 380a:

I open my eyes only to see blackness. My mouth feels like I'm chewing on a jellyfish. A weird gummy sensation, one that feels electrifying. I'm laying on the ground apparently, and when I raise my hand up to rub my forehead, I'm somewhat surprised when something stops me just short of doing so.

Oh, right. The hypersuit. Even with all its enhancements, I can't see a thing around me, or myself. Oddly enough, the inside of my Hypersuit is slightly illuminated, but the usual heads-up-display that I can see isn't on.

Wait! I remember now! I absorbed a star, and then I felt tired! Have I been asleep for a long time? I don't even know. "Centurion, how long have I been out?"

Seconds pass but no response. The suit seems completely inert, as if all of its systems have shut off. I don't know how to shut them down though... maybe they're burned out?

" **Location.** " I speak a word to figure out where I am, but it takes several seconds before anything happens. Finally, a word appears in my mind. *Unknown.*

Unknown? What the heck does that mean?

This suit feels stifling. I'm getting claustrophobic. Tentatively, I pull my helmet off and breathe in, surprised that it seems like there's oxygen... wherever I might be. When I tilt my head to look downwards, I notice the glowing that was inside of my helmet is somewhat more pronounced now, and I can see the front of my suit. It looks slightly banged up, but not damaged in a way that would make me think it had to shut down or anything. What's going on?

" **Remove.** " I wordsmith again, this time aiming at my suit. Several seconds pass, and just when I'm starting to wonder what's going on with my Wordsmithing, the suit abruptly vanishes, along with the rest of my clothes. Geez, this might be embarrassing if I weren't all alone in a pitch black void.

Only once my suit is gone do I finally see what's going on. My entire body is glowing, in a similar manner to Sensei's. The difference is that his glowed white, and his skin was slightly translucent. Mine, however, is colored bright yellow. When I hold my hand to stare at it, a small amount of electricity jolts off one of my fingers before dissipating an inch or so away from my body.

If I didn't know any better, I'd say I was supercharged... like some sort of battery.

And that's when the pain hits. I start to stand up, and suddenly my heart pounds and I wheeze loudly, stumbling forward and nearly falling on my face. I breathe hard and feel a weird cold sweat arrive from nowhere, but soon the feeling passes and all that's left is a painful clenching in my stomach.

Shit. I think it was a bad idea to absorb that star. Maybe because it was a different kind of energy compared to magical energy, it's like trying to gain the ability to breathe fire by eating a hundred hot candies at once.

My body isn't just glowing though; there also appears to be a faint skin-layer aura that surrounds and permeates me. Somehow, I know just by looking at it that if I didn't have this aura, I wouldn't be able to breathe right now.

I look down at the Hypersuit crumpled at my feet and shrug. It doesn't work right now anyway, might as well put it away. " **Storage.** "

Several seconds pass again, and finally, the suit vanishes. What the hell? Is something going on with my wordsmithing? That's the third time in a row it's suffered delays.

I don't know where I am, but I need to return to Mars. " **Tele-** "

" **-port.** " I'm only halfway done finishing the word when I immediately vanish from the void and appear on a familiar landscape, one with a dull crimson tone that surrounds me everywhere. The rapid change of scenery surprises me, as if I teleported here using my standard mental teleportation, and not via my Wordsmithing teleportation. That's not possible though since mental teleportation can't cross dimensions or vast distances without a huge energy cost.

Speaking of which, I might be wrong, but my energy seems quite a bit higher than before. That can't be right though; this feeling doesn't seem like a logical increase.

My pondering thoughts are interrupted when I blink and realize what I'm looking at. Corpses line the landscape, human and clone bodies are everywhere. I'm shocked to see my own face staring back at me wherever I look, some of them horribly mutilated, while others are decapitated in such a precise manner that it's hard to believe they're gone.

I can't tell one clone from the other, but I can still see a faint glow left behind that surrounds their bodies and slowly is evaporating upwards with a trickle of particles. Not just them, but the humans as well. My clones glow blue, the humans white.

That doesn't make sense. Why can I see an aura?

Where is everyone? How long have I been out of the loop? Am I... the last one here?

I tilt my head back up and look to my left, finally noticing that the city of Termina Ursa is only a few miles away. The fire rises, and I begin to notice the sounds of crumbling

infrastructure, but no firefights or battles are going on. The entire planet is unnaturally quiet.

A flash of movement to my side. I jerk my head to look at it and am surprised to see a metal being, one who is robotic in nature. Without a doubt, this is a Sentinel.

The Sentinel doesn't move. It seems to gaze into my eyes as if it's evaluating me. Then it surprises me by actually speaking.

"Human. You are the one Unarin spoke of named Jason Hiro. Is my analysis correct?"

I narrow my eyes and feel my gut clench up again as a small wave of pain surges through me. Still, I keep standing up straight and make sure not to break eye contact. "That's right. And you're a Sentinel. You and your kind killed my clones and the humans around here. Is that about right?"

The robot takes a few moments to respond, and during that time I feel an odd humming sensation fill the air. It seems like a bunch of bees are buzzing all around me. Weird.

"I am the only Sentinel not to partake in the joy of this slaughter. My designation is Mulgris. I am the leader of my kind."

Mulgris, huh? I think Hawkeye mentioned that name. This robot must be the real deal.

"What's preventing you from attacking me? Afraid?"

The robot tilts its head up ever so slightly. "Fear is a primitive sensation felt by Class 2 life-forms. I am a Class 5 life-form. I have no such need of those emotions. As for you, I am merely evaluating you. You possess the same facial structure and DNA signature as that of the thousands of commander units we've killed, yet every other signature is completely different."

It seems to move backward ever so slightly. "Moreover, your energy signature is unlike that which we have faced before. I have concluded you must be a new lifeform."

Before I can respond, I perceive more rapid motion, this time behind me. I quickly turn my head around and see several hundred other Sentinels have appeared behind me, with blurs of motion denoting even more arriving. They're moving at ludicrous speeds, appearing as blurs even to my trained eyes.

" **Percep-** " Before I can finish wordsmithing to improve my perception, I feel the sensation of time slowing down instantly, making me wonder what the hell is seriously going on right now. The blurs I could scarcely see at all before move at much more reasonable speeds now, and I can finally perceive their legs moving to propel themselves forwards.

These metal hunks of junk are real monsters.

Mulgris speaks again. "Jason Hiro, if that is your actual designation. We have eliminated all organics from this planet and the space surrounding it. However, we detected a temporal tear, and it vanished before we could reopen it. You will take us to the rest of your kind, and in exchange, we will spare your life."

I smile at him finally, feeling a bit of tension ease up. "Couldn't catch all of them, huh? I had hoped they would remember the emergency evacuation protocols. Thank you for letting me know they've escaped." I raise an eyebrow up and lean slightly forwards towards Mulgris. "You don't really think threatening me will give you access to them, do you?"

A flash of motion. Pain explodes across my face, and I'm horribly disoriented before I can even understand what just happened. Several seconds pass and I blink, realizing Mulgris or one of its lackeys must have hit me, sending me flying backward and smashing into the dirt.

A few moments later though, the pain vanishes, and I quickly stand back up.

Mulgris is several hundred feet away, but it closes the gap instantly, arriving before me and stopping to stand perfectly still once again. I feel that same weird humming sensation for a second before it speaks. "Extremely high regeneration levels. You are unlike the other commander units."

I'm getting angry now. This... worthless pile of bolts... it and all of the other Sentinels attacked humanity, wiped us out, and now it thinks it can hit me and get away with it?

I don't even know if Amelia is okay, or anyone else. I can't worry about them though, because right now I'm pissed. I'm really goddamn angry.

I stand up slowly and dust myself off, realizing that I'm still not wearing any clothes. Before I can even wordsmith to put something on, clothes start forming on my body to cover me up.

Thoughtsmithing.

The word appears in my mind, unbidden. I lick my lips slowly at the thought. Is it possible? Is that what's going on here? Have I somehow mutated into an advanced stage of my hero ability?

Better test it out. As Mulgris stares at me silently, I aim my mind at it and imagine a metal coffin surrounding him. A second later, it appears, enclosing him in an instant. A few seconds later the container explodes outwards, evidently not being nearly robust enough to contain the Sentinel.

Melt.

I think the word and aim it at the robot, but nothing happens. Then I remember what Sensei told me... they have some way to nullify direct magic aimed at them. But Umi informed me that

with enough power, this might not be such a barrier.

"Umi, are you listening?"

The Sentinel shifts slightly. "My designation is not Umi."

"Yes, Jason Hiro. I am listening." A familiar computerized voice is audible from a comm tower nearby, broadcasting via a loudspeaker from the now-ruined command post.

"Do you have any hypotheses about my body currently? I absorbed a star."

"An interesting move, one that is sure to provide much stimulation for my processors. I had surmised such a move might enable you to pass beyond your limits; however, I also considered it was not without its risks."

"Such as?"

Mulgris continues to stare silently and evaluates our conversation while we speak. It occurs to me that it and Umi are not related, and thus Mulgris might lack a lot of information regarding specifically how my powers work. Or not. Difficult to say.

"A star uses an energy type that should be incompatible with your human body. If the absorption succeeded, I could only presume you will experience numerous unknown side effects. I have no information on what may occur. As usual, your low-level intelligence manages to interest me."

Fucking hell. She's mocking me again. "Thanks, Umi. You're the best."

Still... numerous side effects, huh? If a bit of stomach cramping and heart palpitations are all I'm experiencing, that seems like a good tradeoff. "Umi, how much has my power level increased?"

There is a short pause before she answers. "Roughly by a scale of 800,000 times what it was before."

I continue to stare forwards, but I feel incredulous. Is... is this why the Sentinels have not attacked me yet? Are they evaluating my combat abilities?

I don't even know what I'm capable of. This should be enough power to have saved Earth when the Moon came crashing down. Why didn't Umi tell me about this?

"Mulgris. I ask you again... are you afraid of me?"

I don't give him a moment to respond. "You killed many of my friends. If you aren't afraid now, you will be."

Wordsmithing doesn't work on the Sentinels, huh? Maybe I don't need wordsmithing. I hold my hand up and imagine a sword appearing. A moment later, a scale replica of Excalibur

appears, and though this is a fake, it will suit my purposes. I slash at my arm and wince slightly, but the wound heals up almost instantly. Then I stab through my hand and yank the blade out, but the pain feels even less than it was before.

Invincible. I thoughtsmith and my desire comes to mind. When I stab the sword at my hand once again, it hits my skin and stops, as if my skin has become like iron. I lose feeling in my body like what always happens, and the lack of touch sensation is a bit jarring, but it will have to do. Can't take a chance with Sentinels.

Speed. Speed. Speed. Speed. I stare forwards at the robot in front of me, as it smugly evaluates me, thinking it knows anything about me.

For a full minute, I continue to thoughtsmith, eventually working on my perception. At some point, I begin to see individual microscopic drops of vapor form in the air as the atmosphere itself halts around me.

Calmly, I walk to the side and smile as Mulgris' single red iris stares forward at the spot I was at before. Unlike before I absorbed the sun, my energy has barely dropped at all despite the amount of time slowdown I'm subjecting myself to. Previously, this level of slowed time would deplete my reserves in an instant.

But now...

I reach over and grab the Sentinel by the neck, then drag it over to all of the other ones. I toss it lightly forwards but the instant it leaves my grasp, Mulgris is suspended in midair.

How fast am I moving right now? I'm not sure. It's time to take a walk.

Teleport.

* * *

I arrive in Heaven. As expected, the place is teeming with humans. I breathe a sigh of relief as I glance around and see hundreds of clones in the immediate area surrounding the Temple of Artemis. Average humans litter the landscape as far as the eye can see, and miles away there are faintly visible hulls of starships that were brought here. Nice work, clones.

Locate.

I immediately search for and find Sensei, as well as a few other key clones. Harold is also located, as is Helen and a few others, but I feel weird. Amelia isn't here. I can't locate her anywhere, in fact.

Is she dead? Is that possible? It makes no sense. Amelia is the one who will kill Satan! If she dies after the cosmos has gone to all this effort to keep things on the same path, it will baffle my mind.

Maybe there's another explanation. I teleport over to Sensei, who has his helmet off and his glowing skin is visible. A quick glance at his head and my arms tells me what I need to know. My skin is not the same as his. Whatever is happening to me, it's different.

Sensei is standing at attention, with a hand waving at someone and he appears to be in the middle of directing some various activities. It looks like the fallback to Heaven was a good backup plan.

Normalize.

I bring myself back to normal speed and appear in front of Sensei. It takes him a second, but he hops back in surprise. "Original?! You're back? Where have you been?!"

My arrival makes all of my clones nearby look up in alarm. In fact, I feel their gazes turn and home in on me, no matter where they are in heaven. I feel like a beacon that draws their attention.

"I absorbed a star."

My simple explanation makes Sensei smile weakly. "You... absorbed a star? We lost thousands of clones, and millions of humans, but at least you were off having fun."

He pauses again and fidgets slightly. "Come to think of it; my chest hurts suddenly. There's a weird feeling emanating from you right now."

I take a minute and explain what's happened, and he simply nods along before explaining what happened during the Sentinel attack.

"Umi told me there might be some side effects, but other than a bit of internal pain, nothing serious has happened yet. I'm adapting remarkably well."

Sensei finally shakes his head. "You're powerful for sure. But at this rate, I don't see even you beating the Sentinels. They move too fast and hit too hard. Wordsmithing is nullified against them for the most part, and that which isn't, doesn't hurt them at all. We don't have a prayer."

"I wonder about that." I chew on my finger slowly, realizing I still can't feel a thing. It's almost like I'm gnawing on a rock. "Where is Amelia? I can't locate her."

Sensei frowns. "I don't know. I've been busy trying to get the millions of refugees settled. Last I saw, she was aboard the Mothership."

"She isn't there. I can't find her even with wordsmithing."

Sensei suddenly seems worried. "There are only a few ways that 'locate' can't find someone, Original. They have to be inside of an anti-energy field, inside a whole other universe... or dead."

"I can't let myself think like that. Amelia isn't dead. She's far too hardy. She has to kill Satan, after all."

A thought occurs to me. "The last time I saw Amelia was moments before I left to absorb the star. Maybe she went searching for me when I left abruptly. I just didn't have time to explain what I was doing."

"Yeah, maybe that's it. Possibly." Sensei doesn't seem too sure. "I can help you look for her, but I need to finish here first."

"That's fine. I need to finish with the Sentinels first. Amelia is important to me, but if I don't stop the Sentinels quickly, there's no telling what will happen next."

Sensei's smile fades away. "If only you knew. You weren't there... didn't see it firsthand. Nothing could stop them. Watch yourself, Original. If you die... I don't know what will happen next, especially to the clones. We might all disappear."

"Yeah, I know. Don't worry, they can't kill me. I'm far stronger than them now."

Sensei glares at me. "How many times have you- have WE said that? Don't get cocky. A power-up, no matter how big, is nothing compared to what can go wrong when we overestimate our abilities. Remember what happened to Earth!"

He shakes his head and turns away, and of course, I know he's right. "Yeah. I'll keep that in mind. Take care of yourself."

I spare a long look in the direction of the spaceships before thinking again. *Teleport.*

* * *

When I arrive back down on Mars, I quickly realize that there are far more Sentinels here than there were before. Mulgris appears before me in an instant.

"Your threat level has been designated as Extremely High. However, due to your superior genetics, we desire to apprehend you so that we might conduct experiments in order to adequately determine whether the integration of your abilities into our systems might be possible. Your consent is unnecessary."

A thousand explosions impact me as microscopic lasers smash into my body in an uncountable number of places. However, I stand perfectly still, as I can't feel any of the attacks. Still, I'm surprised by my ability to perceive such small attacks. Sensei was right that they use microscopic lasers, but there's no way I should be able to see such things. Have my senses been enhanced too?

The attacks cease, and I feel a tremendous humming in the air, which stops a few moments later.

"Our attacks are having no effect on you. They should be destroying you at the cellular level."

I silently wordsmith my speed and perception back up, this time adding in a massive dose of strength. "Sounds like you don't like it when a bigger, badder fish treats you like a plaything."

I grab Mulgris by the foot and hurl him into one of the nearby smaller Sentinels, though he freezes in midair as he leaves my grasp. Dashing forwards, I systematically begin grabbing each sentinel and throwing them at the same spot, into one massive pile. Time is all but frozen now, so with the speed at which I'm hurling them, it's probably a significant percentage of the speed of light.

Many minutes pass as I dash around, piling them all together in one massive heap, though some of the giant Sentinels have to be punched forwards since I can't wrap my arms around them. The whole time, my energy scarcely dips down at all.

Finally, once the pile of tens of thousands of Sentinels is created, I thoughtsmith a massive bag around them, made of highly enhanced materials that should hold their weight. Following this, I create a pitch black void dimension, one just like what I woke up inside not even an hour ago. Finally, I create a portal, and use my enhanced telekinesis to shove the several story tall bag inside of the portal before destroying it.

In the span of a few real world seconds, I've sealed the Sentinels into another dimension.

It was... so simple. Can they escape? I don't know.

I teleport to the dimension I shoved them into. *Normalize.*

Returning to standard time, it takes only a few moments before they erupt from the bag, somewhat confused by where they are now. I can hardly even see them, so I mentally wordsmith *Illuminate* to brighten the place up. An unseen light source allows them to see me, and Mulgris steps forward immediately.

"Human. What is this place? Why have you brought us here?"

"You're the hyper-intelligent death robots. Why not take a guess? You have plenty of time to think."

It only takes a moment to respond. "You plan to seal us here."

"Not really 'plan' to. I've already done it. Since Umi said she couldn't shut you down, and you can't travel to the dimension where we've hidden the humans, this seems like a fitting place to leave you."

Many seconds pass and Mulgris swivels its head to look at the other Sentinels, as that strange humming feeling spreads through the air again.

When Mulgris turns back, I wait expectantly for it to say something clever, but instead, I feel a stinging pain as every Sentinel at once hits me with green lasers. Alarmingly, I realize in an instant these are anti-energy lasers.

Despite the power the lasers once held over me, I feel as though they aren't hurting at all like they used to. I vanish instantly via teleportation and arrive back on Mars.

The Sentinels can't follow me. I've trapped them.

I... won?

It feels like a hollow victory. They killed millions, and the best I could do was trap them. Perhaps.... there's another way.

Locate.

I hunt for Unarin, but the search comes up blank. I can't find him at all.

What the heck? Is he hiding? Maybe he wrapped himself inside of an anti-energy field in order to hide from me.

Unarin... Amelia... I can't find either one. I need to find both of them.

Wait, there's another way. I turn back to that broadcasting tower from Earlier. "Umi, can you locate Unarin for me?"

"Naturally." Her grating awful robotic voice responds for once with a simple affirmation. "Unarin is dead."

"He's dead? How? Why?"

"The Sentinel identified as Mulgris killed him. I do not understand the reasoning. The Sentinels are flawed, in that they were originally created from the minds of physical beings. As such, they possess small traces of emotion and other such unnecessary logical information constrictors. Their motivations mostly evade me."

"Oh." I don't know what to say. I always assumed he would go out in a blaze of glory. Are the Sentinels that powerful? Were they able to crush him that quickly? "Umi, is there a way I can eradicate the Sentinels completely with my Wordsmithing?"

"There is." A female voice responds, but it isn't Umi's. "I would advise against it though."

I turn around and narrow my gaze. It's not possible. It... can't be. "Marie? What are you doing here? I killed you!"

The redheaded woman shrugs and takes a puff of a cigarette. "You did. Or at least, sort of. You're a smart guy, how do you think I'm here now?" I shake my head slowly in disbelief and she exhales some smoke and grins. "I'm joking, you're an idiot. Obviously I'm not the original

Marie. I'm a clone. She made several hundred of us and scattered us all over the place. We're protected by anti-energy, so even if you wanted to locate all of us, you wouldn't be able to."

"I find that hard to believe."

"Believe what you want. I'm standing right here." She holds her hand up. "Also, don't go crazy and kill me again. Not only is it pointless, I'm here to help. I don't want to be crushed by a goddamn boulder."

"I wasn't going to kill you." I'm lying, of course. I totally want to... maybe she has something worth hearing.

"Of course not. Anyway, I'm here because I need to be. I was monitoring Mars following the Sentinel attack and was quite surprised when they began to mass outside of Termina Ursa. The fact you're here and... glowing yellow... tells me you did something pretty remarkable."

I don't respond, and she continues. "You told Umi you absorbed a star. Is that correct?"

There's no point denying it at this point. "Yeah. I did."

"Right. Honestly, I hadn't even considered you could do such a thing. Anyway, I'm just here to warn you not to take things too far. I don't want another C137 on my hands."

"A what?"

"Nothing."

She's cryptic, as always. I keep that thought to myself.

"Marie, what are you trying to get at? I have things to be doing right now."

She stares at me silently for a moment before lifting her head up to look at the darkening blood-red sky. "I'm not a bad person, Jason. You know that, right?"

"Huh? What's this about now? I'm not a pastor, and this isn't the confession booth."

She shakes her head slowly. "You misunderstand. I have done nothing wrong, from my point of view. I'm a greedy, selfish person. I only care about myself, but that doesn't make me a bad person."

She's acting awfully weird. "You killed millions of humans in the Americas with the world-shocking Earthquakes. Your anti-energy weapons led to the Volgrim and the Demons all but exterminating the Angels, and in kind finishing the job later on. I wouldn't call those good deeds."

"You killed trillions of Volgrim, billions of demons, and are thus at least partially to blame for the destruction of Earth, and therefore 90% of humanity. You don't have a lot of room to talk."

Her words sting. "Marie, I don't have time for this. Get on with it."

She flicks the cigarette off to the side and puts her hands on her hips. "You said once that in the future you come from, humanity was put inside of bubble worlds, the demons ruled everything, the angels were gone, and there was no sign of the Volgrim. Sound about right?"

"Yeah."

"Then apparently we're heading on the path to repeating things. My question to you is 'why not'? Were humans in peril in the future? Considering what remained of the races, didn't things seem rather balanced to you?"

I lower my head slowly. "Yes, I have considered that. Are you asking me to recreate the future intentionally?"

"I am. Humanity, so long as it continues to gain new information and new weaponry, always craves more. Perhaps by forcing humans to live in feudal societies, you can allow them to live peacefully. Not coexisting alongside the demons, but living away from them, where they can do no harm."

"What about the Sentinels? I can't leave them be."

"I agree. I suspect that where you stuck them won't last forever. I don't expect that magic is impossible for beings other than heroes and angels and the demons to obtain. Hell, given time, I might even be able to become someone with magical power. Think of the Enforcers, for example."

"So... what you're saying is... the Sentinels may be able to harness the power of magic, given time?"

She lowers her head, and our eyes meet. "Exactly. They're unbelievably dangerous now. Without a doubt, given a chance, they will become unstoppable if that should happen."

"So I need to destroy them."

"Yes. However, their bodies are not made of ordinary metal. The substance they use is something new. It doesn't exist in our known periodic table. I suspect it's some form of living metal which reforms itself once destroyed. The atoms 'learn' the positioning of other atoms nearby and can rebuild if their neighbors are destroyed."

I sigh deeply. "Come on, Marie. Layman terms, please."

Thankfully, she keeps it simple. "Much like how you can heal yourself if you're injured, they can fully regenerate from just a single leftover fragment."

"How would you possibly know that?"

"You were gone a long time. Your clones nearly destroyed the Sentinels, several times over. I had many opportunities to witness it."

Somehow her reply feels disingenuous. I ignore the feeling.

"Marie... I can deal with the Sentinels later. Right now, I have to deal with- URRGH." I suddenly double over in pain as a wave of nausea overtakes me. The pain from the absorption has arrived in full force, and now I'm doubled over in agony in front of a mortal enemy. There's no way she won't take this chance to stab me in the back.

It turns out I'm wrong. Marie watches silently until I can pick myself up. Sweat pours down my face, and I feel haggard, but she just continues to stare. "You okay? That looked rather painful."

Her tone is filled with biting sarcasm. "Stuff it. Probably just side effects from absorbing an entire star."

"Yes, I can see that." She shrugs. "Oh, by the way, Satan wanted me to let you know something."

My suspicions instantly dial up to eleven. "Yeah? What's that?"

"He has your girlfriend. The one with the long black hair."

Her voice is so calm, but I'm immediately filled with rage. "What?! He has Amelia?! Why? What reason could he have?!"

She smiles and laughs. "Like I know! He seems so dismal lately! Anyway, if you can find him, you'll find her. Hop to it!"

I can't help but stare at her silently for several moments. Was that all she was leading up to? Was she just leading me around like a dog on a leash?

"I should really kill you."

"Do what you please. There are hundreds more to replace me." Despite saying this, she deftly reaches down to her side and presses a previously unseen button on her belt. "Toodles."

With a flash of bright light, Marie vanishes, and I'm left wondering what the hell's going on in the universe.

Where did Satan hide Amelia?

Part 381a: Culmination

Satan wants to play hide and seek. I'm not having it. Without a doubt, this is a trap. If I rush into it, Satan will laugh all the way to the bank.

My best option is to get some backup.

Teleport.

I arrive back in Heaven right in front of Sensei, and he jumps back in fright. "Goddammit! Stop doing that!"

"Sorry. This is important. Satan has Amelia, and he's openly invited me to use 'locate' to find him. It has to be a trap."

Sensei stares at me silently for a moment. "You do love Amelia, right?"

"What? Of course. That's why I have to save her." Sensei's question throws me off. "Is now really the best time for philosophy?"

Sensei scratches his glowing forehead and sighs. "Look, you and I both know how the future played out. We don't know the details though. Amelia is supposed to kill Satan, that's how it should go down."

"Yeah, what's your point? Where are you going with this?"

"I'm just asking if you're serious. Satan is probably going to manipulate you. He might use her as leverage to force you into a battle on uneven terrain, especially now that your power levels are a million times higher than before. Unlike me, he can sense your aura after all."

"He's going to use her as a hostage somehow, then?"

Sensei smiles, but his expression is filled with pain. "Without a doubt. That's how the demons operate. Give them an inch, and they'll use it to stab you in the eye."

"That doesn't make sense."

"Shut up."

Finally, for the first time today, both of us laugh for a moment before getting serious again.

"Are you ready, Sensei?"

"Yeah. Just take us there already."

"You asked for it."

I aim my mind at the vast cosmos around me. *Locate. Teleport.*

* * *

We arrive at a bland, empty, desolate landscape, and immediately I duck down and look around quickly. This place is completely flat, and there's nothing but the dirt under my feet. No hills, no rocks, no rivers, not even a few patches of grass. Just dirt as far as the eye can see. The air smells empty, unlivable. The silence is unnerving.

This place is an artificial dimension, without a doubt.

"Glad you could join us." Satan's voice speaks aloud and nearly makes me jump out of my skin, though Sensei isn't affected at all. As if by magic, or rather, *because* of magic, an invisible veil parts in front of Sensei and I to reveal Satan, Marie, and Amelia. Amelia is unharmed and... she looks completely *bored*. What?

"Jason! Finally, you're here! I've been waiting for like, ten hours, you know." Amelia's lilting voice tapers off almost immediately as she finishes the sentence and glowers at me cutely. "It's not nice to keep a lady waiting."

Satan rolls his eyes. "As promised, there he is. Go ahead." He waves his hand, and Amelia hops over to me and smiles cheerfully. "We've been talking about ALL sorts of things! You wouldn't believe it!"

I'm confused. "You're not a prisoner? I thought he was using you as a hostage."

She raises an eyebrow. "As if! You're hysterical sometimes! Also wow, you're all glowy and stuff! Cool!"

Even Marie seems a bit perturbed. "She would not stop yammering about how Satan had to be terrified of her because she's the one who will kill him. She thinks she's invincible."

" *Knows*. It's not a guess." Amelia sticks her tongue out at Marie, before reaching over to grab my hand. "Jason, I-"

The moment she touches my hand, a powerful bolt of electricity leaps off and zaps her, making her yelp in surprise as she jerks back and rubs her hand. "Owie! What the heck!"

I suddenly feel guilty and want to say sorry, but I didn't realize my recent power-up had changed me so much. "S-sorry. I devoured a star and my body changed a bit."

She looks away from my eyes sheepishly. "Actually, I might have liked it."

Uh. *What?*

"I'm going to barf. Let's not forget why we came here, Original." Sensei groans audibly and gestures towards the demon and the human before us.

Marie and Satan both look at each other for a moment and grimace. Now I feel self-conscious.

"We'll talk about this later, Amelia. I'm glad you're safe."

"Of course I'm safe! What, you thought Satan could kill me? He's scared to death! Just look at him!" Amelia gives me a *duh* expression and looks back at Satan with a stupid grin on her face. "Are you going to admit it finally?"

Satan shakes his head slowly. "There are a great many things that need clarification here, Jason one and two. The first is the matter of her invincibility. It's absurd. If killing her was my goal, I'd have easily done so already. She is nowhere near my level."

Amelia gawks at him, but I step in before she can blabber again. "Right, I get it. Stop wasting my time. I have an army of death robots to figure out how to destroy if you're not here to fight."

"No, I *am* here to fight. Make no mistake, only one of us will walk away today, Jason Hiro. I just needed to confirm something... Jason, are you aware of the existence of parallel universes?"

I shoot a quick glance at Sensei, but he just shrugs. "I've read a few theories. Why?"

Satan smirks. "So you don't know, then. None of the Jasons do, at least not yet. Or if they do know, they've been uncharacteristically quiet. To what end, I cannot fathom. I must presume they lack the knowledge."

Before he can continue, Marie grabs his arm. "Satan, is that what this is about? Don't be a fool. If you tell him, it will-"

Satan glares at her angrily and shoves her to the ground. "Take your hands off me, filthy human! Long have I silently held my tongue and listened to your beguiling words, but it ends today! Everything does! This is the day I finally prove that time is *not* constant! I won't be locked to a future where I must die! I am not going to be crushed by some impudent little girl!" Satan stares at Marie for several seconds before returning to a strange smile that he creepily sends in my direction.

"I had time to speak with your wench. Amelia is nothing special. Belial warned me of a strange power inside of her, yet that power is nothing, in the end. She's even weaker than most heroes I've fought. Not even worth the time to order a minion to kill her. But, you... you have come close to killing me once before. And now, you stand there posed like the first Hero I ever fought. Hercules was a warrior unlike any other, but I crushed him just as I will crush you."

"Big words. I didn't just increase my pool of energy, Satan. I have other abilities now."

Sensei turns to me and speaks almost in a hushed whisper. "He's planning something. Don't let his words distract you."

Satan can apparently hear him. "I have no need for tricks. Look around you! I created a barren landscape for the simple reason that there is no place to hide! I will win today, no matter what actions you take to fight me. It is preordained."

"Jesus Christ, shut up already! You're giving me a headache!" Amelia puts her hands on her hips and starts getting pissy, a rare sight for the usually smiling girl. "You're blabbing like some comic book villain! We've already beaten you in the future, so that means if we didn't kill you here, it would be a paradox! You can't just rewrite the rules of time!"

Satan doesn't seem mad at her comment. Instead, he smiles again and licks his lips. "Weren't you listening? We are not in the only universe. There are many others, ones where Jason doesn't exist, ones where I don't exist, ones where the angels and humans ultimately defeat the demons and Volgrim... and they all stem from a single universe. A single seed."

Satan points at me. "You are the reason, Jason Hiro. Before the event that caused you to rewind time, there was only one universe. One linear timeline. I have long had the memories you gave me to learn how everything works. I confirmed and denied many theories over the years, and now I know for certain it is true. I do not have to die. I can live and rule for all eternity!"

Amelia scoffs. "This whole speech makes me think you're just trying to convince yourself of that. I'm not buying it."

Satan's smile fades away. "You don't have to believe me. It's already happened. All I needed was for Jason to make a single critical mistake, and of course, he did not fail to meet my expectations. Funnily, the mistake didn't happen the way I expected it to, but this is close enough. It will have to do."

His crypticness makes the hair on the back of my neck rise. "Get behind me, Amelia. He's planning something!"

She keeps the smile on her face, but I feel as if a crack appears in her facade, and only I can see it.

Satan stares at me listlessly. "It is a great irony that I will take the power of godhood thanks to an ability stolen from my worst enemy. I have only Zeus to thank for this."

Satan reaches his hand up to his face and immediately I thoughtsmith to myself. *Shield!* *Shield!* Two dense layers of energy shields spread around the three of us in an instant as Satan chuckles to himself. "Not fast enough."

Satan bites his hand. A moment later, he vanishes.

What the hell? Where did he go?!

A sickening crunching noise blasts to my side. I whirl my head over and pale as I feel the universe slow down. Sensei's head explodes into a million fragments as Satan delivers a single punch directly into his skull. Just as I catch a glimpse of Satan, the demon vanishes, and I watch silently as my clone falls to the ground, dead.

"S... Sensei?" I stare at his corpse numbly. What happened? How? Satan vanished and then appeared? Teleportation?

Why wasn't Sensei wearing his helmet? Why didn't I think of-
Oh... god.

I look back to Marie right as Satan reappears. "It is done."

Marie stares in shock at Sensei's body. "You... did it."

"I did. I have stolen the power of Wordsmithing."

I can barely even think right now. Bolts of lightning shoot off my body and shred the ground around me as my breathing sharpens and my nostrils flare. "You... killed... my best friend..." My teeth gnash and I feel my eyes bulging.

"Calm down now, Jason. You haven't a prayer of winning. You have Wordsmithing, as do I. However, I also possess the power of hundreds of heroes and angels. I outrank you now." Satan bows and grins widely. "Running away would be advisable."

He's speaking, isn't he? I hear the words, but I can't understand the meaning. All I can do is mentally think the same words over and over as he cackles to himself.

SPEED! PERCEPTION! SPEED! PERCEPTION! SPEED! PERCEPTION!

Over and over, my mind races as I glare into the soulless eyes of the monster that killed my closest friend. His laugh grows slower every second, and momentarily he comes to a standstill as do all the noises around me.

STRENGTH! STRENGTH STRENGTH!

I bellow the words into the recesses of my brain until I can almost feel my body bursting at the seams.

Then I move forwards.

Pounding his body with fists made of a material that can no longer be called flesh, my invulnerable body bashes him countless times every second and I smash him forwards for miles on end, occasionally stopping to grab him by a flailing limb and break him over a knee before whipping him into the ground like a crash test dummy. Far too quickly for him to perceive, I

finally let go and watch as his momentum comes to a screeching halt as his body re-enters normal time.

When I look at his face, my rage fades, and I feel melancholic. He's still smiling, despite everything I just did to him. When I re-enter normal time, will he even know how his death came? Is there a chance?

Why the fuck is he smiling?! It pisses me off! He doesn't have the right to feel joy!

He killed... Sensei. Sensei was more than just a clone. We fought sometimes, quarreled over matters, but he was always there to put me on the straight and narrow. He didn't deserve to go out so unceremoniously. He should have died in honorable combat. I thought Satan was going to aim for me. I thought that Satan was a demon who believed in honorable fights.

I was wrong.

I stare at the smiling face of the demon suspended in midair before me. "I'll never be able to repay you for what you just did to me. This isn't even close."

Normalize.

I reflexively take a deep breath as time reverts, only for a titanic blast of air to erupt in front of me and send me careening backward head over heel at breakneck speeds. Before I know it, I've stopped moving, but the world is still spinning. I can't think straight.

I close my eyes and stifle a sensation of nausea, as that familiar feeling of agony erupts in my stomach again. These side effects still catch me off guard.

Heal. Calm. I try to thoughtsmith, but the pain won't subside. It's like trying to stop a skin tumor by dropping a pill on it. The treatment might be correct, but the method for administering the antidote isn't.

Finally, I force myself to sit up, even though the world won't stop spinning. When I do, I blink in surprise. Satan is standing before me, dusting himself off. A massive crater is blasted out just behind him, stretching for miles in the distance afterward.

"You thought it would be that simple, huh?"

From behind, Amelia and Marie run up, though Marie is gasping for Air and Amelia isn't even slightly winded. "Jason! Are you all right? What happened?!"

I ignore her and stare up at Satan in wonder. "I... you should be... how can you be alive after that?"

"I've had years to prepare, whelp. I played the fool, always letting you get the upper hand when possible. When you came within inches of killing me in New York City, that was when I

knew your powers were the key to unstoppable power. You can't defeat me now, Jason. While I was in Zeus's Hypertime, I cast several powerful wordsmithing spells, one of which was 'invincibility.' The next was 'protect,' followed by 'prevent.' You will not be able to kill me by physical means, you will not be able to harm me via magical means, and you will not be able to undo my wordsmithing protections with your wordsmithing."

Satan smiles and gazes up at the white sky above. "I wondered if this day would come. I might be the only version of myself to have the power to rival the Creator."

I jump to my feet and hustle over to Amelia, keeping her behind me. "The Creator? What do you mean by that?"

Satan shrugs. "Who knows? Nobody has seen the bastard since the beginning of the universe. But thanks to your powers, even he will not be a threat to me. You and I can fight forever, and we'll never kill each other."

His lip seems to tremble for a moment as he finally swings his gaze from the sky to meet my eyes. "Despite all this power, I still hate you. You've killed billions, even trillions of my demons over the years. Not just you, but the gods and angels too. All of you. Even if I kill you a million times over, I can never hurt you in the same way you have done to me."

Marie finally speaks up. "Perhaps there is a way we might make a truce between the three remaining races. We should try and stop this here."

"Not a chance. I've lost nearly everything thanks to this human and his ilk. I'll never forgive them." Satan's nostrils flare out. "All the things you've taken from me... we might be invincible foes who can't harm one another, but we still have weaknesses. And you... you have such a simple one."

His eyes lower and I realize he's looking at Amelia. "Leave her out of this. You've taken enough from me today!"

"I haven't. You deserve eternal damnation, boy." Satan suddenly erupts into derisive laughter. "Hah hah hah! Think of it! You had a power that the Creator himself would envy, yet you never thought of its abstract effects!" Satan's voice goes quiet as Death itself as he speaks a single word. " **Create.** "

A moment later, a tiny marble sized ball of pure blackness appears in the air in front of him. "You had the power all this time. All it would have taken was a little imagination. The word doesn't need to be specific, Jason. You can imagine whatever you like when you speak. You don't *deserve* to have this power."

His eyes dart down to Amelia, and I immediately thoughtsmith in response.

Not this time! Invincibility!

An invisible aura appears and protects Amelia, but Satan stares at me with sadness in his eyes. "So simple minded. I can feel when the magical energy leaves your body. You don't need to speak to wordsmith anymore, do you, Jason? As if that changed things in the slightest."

His deadly gaze makes my blood chill. He continues with a single word. " **Teleportation.** "

He vanishes from in front of me and appears behind Amelia. I whirl around and grab her in a tight embrace as he sends the pitch black marble at us.

"Oopsy." Satan snickers as the tiny marble flies at Amelia, smashes into her back, and explodes. Amelia opens her mouth to gasp, but no sound comes out. A soft warmth spreads across my chest and I look down and feel my breathing halt. Her entire chest cavity is missing. There's nothing but a hole in her back.

Jason. Her lips move, but no sound comes out.

" **HEAL! HEAL!** " I yell the word out and watch in desperation as her eyes go cold. No no no...

Her body slumps in my arms, and a moment later her eyes stare ahead blankly. Her soul has left.

"Wordsmithing can't save the wench now." Satan's smile is gone as he stares at her silently. "Even a god has limits."

I can barely hear him. This is too much. How could he be such a monster? She was no danger to him. He didn't do this because he wanted to get rid of a threat, but because he wanted to wound me.

He killed the woman I love.

Wordsmithing won't save him now.

Part 382a: Oh Dear

Even as I stare at the demon before me and my vision goes red with rage, the warmth of her blood flowing down my arms slows as the heal magic finishes. It's far too late to save her now. I can see the particles from her aura flooding upwards. Just like with that girl in the car crash, the body can be healed, but the soul will not return.

Satan's tongue slips out and licks his lips greedily. "You tried to make her invincible, didn't you? An obvious ploy, one I assumed you would attempt. I already prevented that during Zeus's Quantum Speed, though I didn't have time to prepare for every eventuality. Luckily, you're predictable."

I slowly lower Amelia's body to the ground and caress her eyes with two fingers, closing them softly. "You didn't have to kill her. I can't believe I never realized what a coward you are."

"Punish me, then, if you can! Use your new power to crush me! Perhaps you should try removing my invincibility with your wordsmithing, or maybe you can dream up a weapon that pierces through the power of magic! I'm sure an anti-energy weapon would nullify my invincibility adequately."

He's mocking me. They all are. Everyone calls me an idiot. It's not true though... I'm just lazy. I always think of a simple solution to a problem and then rely on it until it fails. If I had to guess, I would say it's my biggest failing as a member of the exalted Heroes. Arthur's weakness was his guilt, and how he could never forgive himself. I've long since forgiven myself for what I've had to do... but this is different. Amelia is dead because of my inaction. Sensei was crushed faster than I could react. Satan thinks this is a simple game, one that he's planned out meticulously.

Slowly, I stand up until I'm staring eye to eye with the Devil. He's as big and bulky as I am, though not nearly as big as that one demon general of his. To a casual observer, we might appear to be equals, but he seems to be winning in the brains department.

What can I use to pulverize him? He said I should try to undo his invincibility and to use an anti-energy weapon, but that probably means he already has counters for them. He's anticipating my moves again. There has to be a solution. One he doesn't know about...

I swivel my head to look over at Marie. Something has always bugged me. How does one human woman put demon emperors, angels, and heroes to shame on a regular basis? She may be smart, but that can't be all there is to it. She's always so confident as if she has nothing to fear, yet I killed her in the blink of an eye. If this is a clone that I'm staring at, could that explain

her confidence? Even if she dies, there will always be another replacement waiting to take her place?

No. There has to be something else. Perhaps she has a counter devised, beyond what even Satan can see. Maybe she isn't scared of us because if push comes to shove, she can eliminate us whenever she wants. It sounds absurd, but from what I've learned of this timeline, she is directly responsible for the creation of anti-energy weapons.

If she can create anti-energy weapons and a weapon that will cause nearly the entire planet to suffer intense earthquakes, without having an ounce of magical ability... what other secrets does her mind hold?

She eyeballs me calmly as she inhales a lit cigarette. "What? Stop staring at me. He's the one who killed your fuck-toy."

Her words are cruel, almost as if she wants to anger me, wants me to attack in a blind rage. Why? What could she have that would make her think angering an invincible godlike figure is a good idea?

"Marie, is there anything you fear in this world?"

My question makes her eyes narrow in suspicion, and she pulls the cigarette from her mouth. "You're acting weird. Shouldn't you be crying or something? Satan just killed your woman, you know. Aren't you going to punch him or whatever?"

Another deflection. She didn't answer my question. Again, she tries to direct my attention to the Devil before me.

"Perhaps. There will be plenty of time for that. Answer my question. Is there anything in this world that would terrify you and make you lose your cool?"

Satan is staring at me in confusion now. Even he doesn't know what's going on.

Marie scratches her head and shifts uneasily. "I think something in you snapped. Satan, did you wordsmith something that affected his brain? He's never been this direct before."

"Stop ignoring me!" I dash over and grab the front of her shirt faster than her human eyes can follow, then hoist her up into the air. "Answer the goddamn question!"

"What the hell?! Let go of me!" Marie's calm demeanor evaporates, and she punches at my hands futilely. I keep holding her for a few moments, but nothing dramatic happens. Finally, I toss her on her ass and stare in disbelief. I half expected her to attack me with a hidden weapon or something.

The moment she hits the ground, Marie winces, then stands up and rubs her ass. However, that cocky smile is back. "You're scared, aren't you? I think I know what's going on here. You

can't think of a way to beat Satan, so you want to know if I have something that can do it."

Satan takes a few steps towards us, caution evident in his body language. "I would be surprised if you didn't, honestly."

Marie tosses her hair to the side. "The deadliest weapon is one you never have to use. Let that be your answer. Sorry, Jason, but I'll be sitting this one out. You need to beat him on your-"

She stops talking suddenly and freezes, as her eyes suddenly look past Satan and I, to where I had been standing just a few seconds ago. "Hey, you two... that doesn't look normal."

Only now do I suddenly notice a strange feeling of terror I had been ignoring in my body. I thought it was due to adrenaline, but instead, it's...

I look back at Amelia's body and shudder. A strange black mist is flowing out of her nostrils and condensing into a ball above her body. The mist shifts occasionally, as if something is moving around unseen inside of it.

"What the devil is that?" Satan chuckles weakly, even as he takes a hesitant step forwards. His choice of words don't evade me, but I ignore them anyway.

I remember now. I was warned about what would happen. I forgot though, naturally. If Amelia is dead, then this can only be one thing.

Amelia's arms suddenly flail around and her back arches, as her mouth opens, seeming to scream wordlessly. The trickle of black mist turns into a raging inferno of black fire as it rushes to escape its container, rapidly increasing in size above her.

The small orb from before is now the size of several beach balls smashed together, and getting bigger every second. Satan's cockiness from earlier is replaced with deadly alarm. "Jason! What the hell is going on? This is unnatural!"

"No. It makes sense. I should have realized. He's going to be pissed... very pissed."

"*He?*" Satan looks at me incredulously before turning back to gawk at the black mass. It's titanic now, easily the size of a small house.

Half a minute passes and the three of us stare wordlessly until finally, the mist slows to a trickle, then stops.

The air is silent. A colossal orb, the size of a small office building, hovers only a few feet above her body. It's as if she's about to be crushed by a small asteroid, but the asteroid is scared of hurting her.

A voice speaks out, so intense and full of power that the very ground under our feet shakes in fright.

" I have forgotten how to reform my body. "

Satan's alarm instantly turns to terror and his body trembles madly. "Th-that voice! It has to be- I knew you couldn't be dead!" He smiles, but the expression is one of jittery horror. "The... the countermeasure. Marie! Marie, the countermeasure!"

" A moment, if you please. I have finally remembered what I used to look like. " The voice blasts outwards again, and a moment later the blob of blackness shifts. Wings spread out slowly, stretching to a hundred feet in width. Four thick tree-trunks that must represent his legs inch their way out, and the rest of the orb congeals into what can only be described as a fucking dragon made of darkness.

Even I'm scared.

Finally, the dragon lowers down, standing protectively over Amelia's body. He takes a few ginger steps backward, then reaches forward with his leg and nudges her with a single claw.

" So this is what it came to. In the end, my princess was killed by the one I gave great power. My life's choices have finally caught up with me, but she paid the price. " Leviathan nudges Amelia again, but if he's feeling any rage, he doesn't show it at all. Only a sense of deep sadness fills the air.

I become aware of Satan's movements off to my rear. Satan runs forward, rushes past me, and hurls a small object through the air.

I thoughtsmith at the object reflexively. *Identify.*

A rapid series of images appear in my mind almost instantly. It's a grenade of some sort, one that binds the target with a blast of anti-energy by sending a large amount of irradiated shrapnel into key vital areas all at once.

I open my mouth to yell a warning at the dragon, but the device suddenly freezes in midair.

" Oh. I expected better. " Leviathan barely gives the device a passing glance before a tiny black void appears, sucking the grenade in. It vanishes without theatrics, and Satan stares at where it was for a few moments.

"Marie. That was supposed to work."

She shrugs. "I designed based off your description of the dragon. I didn't have anything exact to work with. You're on your own here." With a great sigh she plunks down on the ground and stares at the massive dragon with a look of total disinterest.

Cold sweat is visible on his face now. "Leviathan. It's been a while. I thought you were dead, for a long time. You and Jörmungandr were the final two."

" You speak his name so casually. Michael enslaved him and took his power for himself. With Michael's passing, my own power doubled. I would not die without rending the Earth itself in two. "

Leviathan lowers his ten foot-head down and peers at the small demon before him. **" Enough of the small talk. You have angered me in a way no other has done in all the eons I lived. My only question now is in what manner should I kill you? "**

Satan's breath comes in raspy heaves, but he manages to look tough. "I am not the same demon I was before, black dragon! I have the power of the gods now, and the might of countless heroes! You no longer hold power over me!"

" Mmm. Yes, Wordsmithing. Quantum Time. The Eyes of Manipulation. Battlefield Control. Countless others. All powerful in their own way. With their combined power, you must feel unstoppable. "

The dragon eyes Satan even as the demon smiles faintly. "S-so you acknowledge my incredible power! Even you realize this will not be an easy fight!"

" Easy? You know little of what a true battle looks like. Before the Titans, and the gods, and the angels, and the humans, and the demons, it was the dragons who ruled over the universe. Our battles were cosmic in scale, capable of destroying planets when our blows collided. Over a length of time so vast that the common languages have no words to denote it, our powers combined, becoming more and more condensed. Eventually, when the Titans realized our existence outside of Earth, they began to fear us. "

Leviathan looks down sadly at the small body before him. **" I remember when the great cataclysm occurred on Earth. I was sealed under rubble, but I made no immediate move to escape. It was because I was tired of the unending war. In my moment of weakness, the Titans were given a rare opportunity, and they took it. They created a powerful seal and placed it around me, preventing me from escaping. It took millions of years, but eventually my brothers and sisters, all of them enemies of the highest caliber, fell in battle. "**

" It was you who changed me, Satan. A chance meeting with a small, weak imp who stumbled into my home. I learned that the other sentient creatures in the universe had their own goals, their own small desires. Though simple-minded, their desires were no different than those of the dragons but only smaller in scale. In effect, despite my desire to escape, it was you who taught me empathy. "

Satan stares at the dragon for a few moments. "Why are you telling me this?"

The great dragon raises his head to look up into the white sky above, now slowly shifting colors towards black as he seems to draw in the light toward himself. " **Amelia changed everything. The princess showed no fear in my presence. She looked at me as if we were equal. Equal! A creature I could have crushed with a single scale pulled from my body!** "

" **And you killed her. You took her away from me.** " Leviathan's eyes turn deep black as he lowers his head once again to glare at the demon. " **She was not my equal. She was better than me. She was better than you. A pure creature who I tainted with my evil. Before I merged with her, she would have grown up to be a soft, loving woman. Instead, she became a violent murderer, one I simply had to nudge tacitly, for the alternative was her dying and leaving me forever. If it was a matter of being free, I could have done it long ago. I didn't wish to be free, for I was never a slave inside of her. I was exactly where I wanted to be.** "

Satan looks at me, and his eyes tell a story all by themselves.

" **Take responsibility. Bring her back to me, all-powerful demon. If you do, I will spare you.** " The dragon raises his claw and points it at Satan. " **If you lack the power to bring back the dead, then you will never be able to defeat the last of the dragons.** "

Satan takes a step backward uneasily. "Ah, well, that is to say, I don't think I actually have that power..." He then turns to Amelia. " **Revive! Resurrect!** "

Of course, nothing happens. If it were that simple, I would have done it.

Leviathan looks at both of us for a moment. " **Jason. I am just as disappointed with you as I am angry at Satan. I only gave you one directive, which was to make sure no harm fell upon my princess, yet you failed at even that. Still, I know you cared for her as I did. I am certain you will not make such a mistake in the future ever again.** "

His confidence in me seems odd. I certainly don't feel confident about my abilities right now. I feel like a failure.

Does he know something I don't?

Satan is very uneasy now. "You never talked this much when I knew you. Are you going to fight me now? Surely you're boiling over with anger?"

" **Only somewhat.** " The dragon utters two simple words, opens his mouth, and a second later a colossal blast of dark energy shoots forwards in a concentrated beam, smashing into Satan and pulverizing him deep into the ground below. Leviathan sustains the attack for only a

second or two, but the energy output is on a scale that makes my newly powered-up form feel... somewhat insignificant.

When he finishes, the wind in the area slows back to a breeze, and I take a breath instinctively. "Did you kill him?"

" No. That was just an expression of anger. Such weak attacks will not kill him. "

Weak. Leviathan shot a blast that probably contained 1% of my newly upgraded energy capacity, and he called it weak. What sort of scale does he think on?

Leviathan reaches down and digs his claw into the dirt, scooping Amelia up carefully along with the ground her body rests on. **" Jason Hiro. I am a selfish immortal. All I ever think about is myself. I have a large request for you, if you would accept it. "**

"Uh, okay. What is it?"

" I am going to bring the princess back. Doing so requires the use of magic forbidden by the dragons of the past. Since I am the last of my kind left alive, I will break the rules of an eternity long since passed for my own selfish reasons. However, when she wakes, I will not be here to greet her. "

His words impact me like a cruise missile. "You have to sacrifice yourself to bring her back? But... you're her best friend... what good is living if she can't spend it with you?"

" She will have you. That will have to be enough. I simply cannot go on for an eternity without the one I... the female I care for. This is my final, selfish request. Take care of the princess. "

My mouth is dry as cotton. "Yeah... yeah, I'll do that. I'll make sure no harm comes to her."

" You may not be able to prevent her death in the distant future, but I know you will do your best. Thank you, Jason Hiro. Despite your faults, your imperfections are what make you human. Without flaws, life has no meaning. "

Leviathan reaches his claw over and sets her down next to me. I can't help but stare at her serene face. It's as if she's sleeping now. All the dragon has to do is wake her up.

He truly is on a different scale than the rest of us.

" Take care, Hero. "

He reaches down with the tip of his claw and lightly touches her chest. **" Iliarus, var'uusk dil'ignal, hatuur vree mulsk. "**

The words radiate a power that can only be described as ancient. My thoughtsmithing allow me to translate them into ' *A soul must be given, for one to be taken, this binds our hearts*

together for all eternity. '

For a moment, nothing seems to happen.

Then the world explodes. A torrent of images rushes into my head. A great war in space. Black crows. Energy colored in a manner my human mind can't comprehend. The big bang. A face covered in malice. Eyes filled with sadness. A girl smiling at men riding on camels. A hand resting on a dragons' claw.

The final image is the universe, in all its glory and splendor. All at once, my mind comprehends the true vastness of the cosmos. Words like 'trillions' and 'septillions' are inadequate to explain how insignificant the sentient species are. We will come and go, and the universe will ignore us. Our squabbles mean nothing. Whether we live or die, the universe will not remember us.

Life doesn't matter. When we die, all of our training and learning vanishes. The only trace of us will be left in historical archives, and those will fade with time.

But love, friendship, those can never be recorded. They are timeless. Once you lose them, you cannot ever feel complete again.

This is why he sacrificed himself. From the bottom of his heart, towards Amelia, Leviathan felt...

Ah. My mind reappears in the normal world and I realize with a start that I'm laying flat on the ground, facedown. I don't even know how I ended up here. I pull myself up and spot Marie also trying to stand up, her mind apparently having witnessed the same images mine did. What did they mean?

When I look to my other side, my heart skips a beat. Amelia is standing now, staring at the corpse of Leviathan. His body rests on the ground, motionless. The energy I felt from before is gone.

No... that's not true. I still feel it. Not in Leviathan, but inside of...

"Jason. Why is Levvy here? Why isn't he moving? Is he sleeping?" Amelia's voice is cold. Her eyes aren't blinking. "Why is he taking a nap? He told me dragons don't need to sleep."

"Amelia... Satan killed you. He... released Leviathan. Leviathan... he had to... sacrifice himself..."

The words hurt me to say, but Amelia seems to not hear me. "Dragons don't need to sleep. That's what Levvy always said. Why is he sleeping? Did Levvy lie to me?"

At the most inopportune moment, Satan finally crawls out of the hole he had been buried in, pulling himself up with a strange amount of effort. Didn't he wordsmith 'invincible'? How can

he be this out of breath?

He rasps painfully. "Wh-what? Why is the dragon dead? The girl is walking now. What in the seven hells...?"

Amelia finally seems to register his words. "Levy is dead? He can't die. Levy is too strong to die."

I'm standing behind Amelia, so I shake my head at Satan. *Don't say anything.* I plead with him through my eyes, but he seems to have been hit in the head a little too hard.

"What are you talking about? He's clearly dead! The real question is why you're alive and he isn't?! I was only out for a minute! What happened up here?"

Amelia looks ahead blankly at him for a moment before turning to me. "Jason, is Levy really dead? Satan's lying, right? Demons always lie."

I pull her in close and hug her. "No. I'm sorry. Satan killed you, but Leviathan brought you back. He had to pay a price to do that."

She doesn't hug me back, and barely responds to my embrace. I suddenly feel like I'm giving a wet-fish handshake.

"Oh. If that's true... then that means since Satan killed me, but Levy died to bring me back... Satan killed Levy. Yes, Satan killed my friend. I understand now."

I push her away and stare into her eyes. She doesn't seem to be looking at me, and her eyes are filled with blackness. "Amelia, don't do anything stupid. Calm down. There must be a way to bring him back."

She ignores me and turns her head to look at Satan.

"You took him from me. No more mercy."

Part 383a: Departure, Return

It happens instantly. One moment, my hands are on Amelia's shoulders as she leans away from me. The next, she's gone. I blink to make sure I didn't just hallucinate, and the sickening sound of a fist impacting bone blasts off to my right.

By the time I lift my head to follow the source of the sound, there's nothing there.

"Huh?"

I stare dumbly at the spot where I *know* Satan was just standing, but the only thing there now is a very deep hole that Leviathan blasted him into.

A dumb question enters my mind. *Gosh, I wonder how big this 'planet' is that we're on? That hole sure looks like it goes for a few miles!*

Only when I look a little into the distance, do I finally realize what's going on. Amelia is fighting Satan.

No. It's not a fight. She's hammering him with a force unlike anything I've ever seen before.

"Bring him back." I hear her speak calmly even as she grabs the Devil by his neck and smashes him in the gut several times in the blink of an eye. "Bring him back."

The calm in her voice is completely out of place with the rage evident in her movements. How is she so calm? It's terrifying.

Blood rushes to escape Satan's body, erupting from his nose and mouth at the same time. Didn't he wordsmith himself to be invincible? I couldn't even hurt him before. How is Amelia tearing him apart so easily?

He wheezes out a weak cry of pain and tries to hold up a hand to stop her, maybe even just slow her down, but she lightly tosses him forward and punches his arm so hard it instantly dislocates and wraps around behind his back, slapping his other arm uselessly. His eyes shoot open, but no sound comes out.

Another minute passes as she blasts him with punches containing so much power that my body clenches over and over again. Finally, I can't watch anymore.

"Amelia! Stop!" I teleport over to her and grab her arm as she rears back for another punch, only for her fist to continue moving forwards, which hurls me past Satan and smashes me into the ground behind him.

I tried to grab her arm, but her strength was so overwhelming that it's like I wasn't even there. As I thought, Leviathan must not have just revived her but also sealed his energy inside of

her. After the minimal display of force that the dragon showed, I have no doubt that she's unbelievably powerful now.

But... to overcome the power of invincibility? This is something else. What is this energy that subtly radiates from her body?

I pull myself up and wince as she delivers another flurry of punches to the Demon. He isn't resisting at all anymore, but merely sagging in her grasp. I don't think he's even coherent anymore.

"Amelia! You can't do this! Levvy wouldn't want you to do this!"

Her fist freezes in midair as she holds the demon in front of her for a few moments. "Levvy isn't here anymore. Satan killed him. Satan needs to die."

Despite her perfectly normal tone of voice and the calm way she's speaking, I get a dark feeling that she's far from sane right now.

"I understand. Please... put him down. For me. No matter how hard you hit him, and whether you kill him or don't... it won't bring Levvy back."

Amelia continues to stare at the demon in her grasp for several long seconds, before she finally drops him on the ground. "Jason... you were right. I was wrong. The future can't be changed. There's no point fighting it anymore. I'm going to become a monster and eat people again. I'm going to kill Satan. The demons will end up ruling the universe, despite your best efforts. No matter what you do, the universe will force you down the path it wants."

I slowly walk up to her and gently put my hand on her shoulder. "You heard Satan though. He believes the universe is not set in stone. He believes things can be different. You don't have to do bad things. You can stay a good person... stay at my side. I love you, Amelia. You love me, right?"

"Do I?" Finally she looks at me, but her eyes are hollow. They aren't the eyes I used to dream about every night. "I don't feel like the same person anymore, Jason. I hunger again. I hunger in a way I've never felt before. There's something in my head, speaking to me, and it isn't Levvy. It's dark. It's sinister. And right now, it's only telling me one thing."

She doesn't continue, and I take my hand off her shoulder. "What's that?"

"It's telling me to kill Satan. Kill the humans, and the demons. It even says... to kill *you*." Finally, there's a crack in the calmness and a tear rolls down her face. "I don't want to, though. I don't want to be a bad girl."

Before I can say anything, a voice gurgles at our feet. Satan finally gathers enough strength to speak, though it's hardly even a hoarse whisper. "I wasn't wrong... idiots. I will... win. Even if

you kill me, I win. Do what you must... you will tremble in... terror..."

Amelia never once looks at him as she wipes at her eye. "Listen to him speak, Jason. Demons are evil. They should be eradicated. Humans are also evil. We shouldn't exist. If the Volgrim hadn't destroyed Earth, we would have choked it with pollution and waste."

Finally, I've had enough and I glare at her. "Amelia, that's no way to talk. You can't fall to pieces on me just because Leviathan is gone. There might be a way to bring him back, just as he brought you back. Even if there isn't a way... even if he can't come back... would he want to see you like this?"

Amelia presses her hand to her chest. "I can feel remnants of his spirit, Jason. I know him better than you ever will. If he didn't have to worry about saving his energy to bring me back, he would have killed Satan. Don't lecture me about what my best friend would think." She tilts her head back slightly to look at a familiar corpse. "I'm not trying to tell you what Sensei would ask of you, after all."

I open my mouth to respond, but in a flash, a bolt of energy shoots out from Amelia's spare hand, grabs Satan by his face, and yanks him straight into her palm.

"I'll make the Devil my slave forever. He won't be able to hurt anyone else after that, and I won't even actually kill him. How about that, Jason? I can show mercy even when filth doesn't deserve it."

Filth?

Amelia never talks like this. She's different now.

I see what's going on here. If she takes control of him now, then she'll be able to pull him out to fight against me in the future. I'm writing my own past.

I'm not going to let it happen like this.

Pause.

I thoughtsmith and time freezes around me. This isn't like when I accelerate myself and slow down time, I'm not enhanced even slightly. I can't move, but neither can she.

It gives me time to think, though.

I can't feel emotion anymore. Too many have died. I've become desensitized to it. Sensei had his head crushed, Amelia was killed in my arms, and now Satan is going to die. Worse, I lack the power to save the one I least want to save. If it weren't for repeating the future, I couldn't give two shits if Satan dies or not.

Is it wrong for me to let the future repeat? Everything worked out pretty good, right up until Hope took over my body. What if I let the future play out, but I stay in the shadows to influence things? I'm immortal, and at this point, I'm ready to live for an eternity if that's what it takes.

But there are disadvantages. If I stay alive that long, will I even remember my original goal? If I thoughtsmith 'remember' constantly, I probably will... but 100 million years is a ridiculously long time. Humans have only been around for 40,000 years at most. I can barely even comprehend a number like one hundred million.

And if the future does change? I guess that means I did something right.

It's settled, then. I'll just let the future proceed. Stopping it seems impossible and shifting it seems unlikely. Best to just let the universe take its course.

Somehow, this feels like the wrong choice, but I'm tired of fighting it.

Normalize.

Time returns to normal and I turn to Amelia to speak, but she suddenly jerks her head over to look at me. "Did you just thoughtsmith? Time slowed down. I felt it."

I never got to tell her about thoughtsmithing, but Satan did mention it just before he killed her. Maybe that's how she knows about it.

"I just needed a moment to think."

Suspicion fills her eyes. "You tried to change my mind, didn't you? You thought you could just make me do what you wanted me to with your powers! I can't believe you!"

"What? No! Where is this coming from? I've never used my powers on you!"

She fully turns to look at me and gnashes her teeth. "You do it every night before bed! You give me energy from the children on Mars!"

"Amelia... come on, that's not the same. I do that for your own good."

She looks aghast. "My own good?! Is that how you justify it? If that makes it okay, then trying to make me not kill Satan is also for my own good too, huh?"

Where the hell is this outburst coming from? She's acting completely irrational all of a sudden. "That's not what I meant and you know it. Stop playing semantics."

I can practically see steam pour out of her nostrils as she fumes. "Fine! If you want me to stop playing around, I will."

I don't get a moment to ask what she means. With one swift movement, she hoists Satan up in the air, still holding him by his face. "This is for Levvy, you demon fucker!"

Nothing happens for a moment, then there is a sudden high pitched squeal as Satan's body roars to life and flails his limbs around wildly. "Let go! You bitch! AHHH! LET ME GO! LET GO!" I watch in horror as the energy is sucked from his body up and out of his face, into her hand. Even as he screams and begs for help, she only begins to smile widely and licks her lips.

Within seconds, his body goes limp and his skin sags. She tosses him to the ground and sighs deeply. "I've... been wanting to do that for two thousand years."

I simply stare, shocked, at his corpse. "You killed him."

"Oh come on, Jason! I've killed tens of thousands of humans and demons over the years, often in the most brutal torturous ways possible! I gave him the pleasure of a quick death, and now he's bound to me forever!"

An uncomfortable silence fills the air. Amelia is the one to speak first. "It's over between us."

The sudden statement floors me. "What? Why?"

"I can't look at you the same anymore. I remember the talk we had, not long ago. You told me there was an orb that housed a being that was eerily similar to Levvy. I wanna find out if it exists, since this is the same timeline as the one you came from."

I can only stare dumbly at her before my eyes drift down to Satan's corpse. "What happened, Amelia? You're different. Leviathan warned that if his power was unleashed on you, your mind would snap. Is that what happened?"

She sneers at me, a gross expression I could never have pictured on her beautiful face. "My mind has indeed changed, but now I see the truth. You never really cared for me. You just wanted to make sure I was your pet project, your final tool to prevent the future from happening. In the end, you tried to betray my needs in order to fulfill your own desires. As long as I let Satan live, that future couldn't happen."

She gestures at the landscape around us. "Take a look! You failed! It's happening! I'm sorry to disappoint you, Jason. I really am. But in the end I understand now that you just used me. You never really cared."

Her words sting, but more than that, they piss me off. I reach forwards and slap her as hard as I can. It's a brutal gesture, one that would kill a normal human girl. For Amelia, it barely even tilts her head, as I knew it would. "Snap out of it! You're full of shit! I do love you, and I don't care if you love me back! I didn't go through all those trials with you just to have you leave me in the end! We have to stick TOGETHER!"

She reaches up and rubs the side of her face. "Do we? I had the man of my dreams already, and he's gone now. He's gone because I was a selfish child. I wanted to have it all, but now I

realize I lost the thing I cared about most in the world."

I feel my lip trembling. Tears are starting to form. Why did it have to come to this?

"I did as well, Amelia. I'm losing you."

Both of us stare into each other's eyes for a few long moments. Through a fleeting glance, I almost feel like her eyes soften towards me. They harden again a moment later. "If you really loved me, Jason, then use your time travel. Do it all over again, but don't screw up this time. They say love will always find a way, so if that's true... I'm going to find a way to bring back Levvy." She tilts her head to stare at Satan's corpse before giving it a hard kick.

Time travel... huh? Yeah... maybe. Maybe not. Time travel sucks. I hate it. If I have to feel this way in the end, it wasn't worth it.

No. That's not true.

I reach over and touch Amelia's face, the spot where I hit her. She doesn't pull away. "Better to have loved and lost than to have never loved at all. If you are going your own way, I'll go mine. As long as it makes you happy."

To my surprise, she reaches up to hold my hand, pressing it against her face. "It's not that I hate you, Jason. Really. I've just realized... I care more about..."

"I understand. You don't need to explain, Amelia. If you ever want help, you know where to find me." I reach over and pull her close, hugging her long and tenderly. This time she reciprocates, and I can finally feel some hesitation in her body. As I have that thought, she eases away and takes a couple steps back.

I just... can't understand women sometimes.

"Don't be a stranger, Jason." Amelia smiles weakly at me, looks away, then makes a small motion with her hands. A moment later, she vanishes.

I don't know if I'll ever see her again.

There's a small bit of movement to my side, and I suddenly remember it wasn't just Amelia and I up here. Marie is here too.

"So heartwarming. I think I'm going to fucking vomit." Marie stares at me, disgust spread all over her face. "So what's next? You gonna kill me, like she killed Satan?"

"No." I don't even hesitate. "There's been enough death today. I have... one last thing to take care of... and it's going to be hard to do."

A look of realization appears in her eyes. "The Sentinels."

"Yeah. Now I know what I have to do to put an end to them. Satan gave me the key, ironically enough. I just had to realize it."

Marie lowers her eyes to his body. "Satan, huh... he died so... unceremoniously. For a godlike being, he was absolutely crushed by that woman. Was the dragon really that strong? How does your power compare to Amelia's right now?"

I lick my lips slowly. "It doesn't. I don't think I could defeat her as she is. And... the fact someone could beat her in the future I came from is... ludicrous."

A name appears in my mind. *Joan*.

She was a legend in the time I came from, spoken of in fearful whispers by demons and humans alike. If I am godlike, what is she? In order to defeat Amelia, Joan must have been a woman of far greater character than I.

Aren't I supposed to be the last Hero to have been born? How does Joan arrive to fight Amelia? Can I prevent it? Should I?

Maybe it doesn't even matter. Perhaps if I get in the middle, I'll be killed.

It's not like I'm afraid of dying. I have nothing left to lose besides my own life.

Marie stares at me as she lights another cigarette. "If you're not going to kill me, then I'd best be going. A woman's work is never done."

"We're not friends, or allies, Marie. You should retire from villainy, or the next time I see you, I won't be so lenient."

"I wouldn't have it any other way. I think you'll find there's more than one woman in this universe who can kick your ass." Marie turns around to walk away, but I stop her.

"Wait. Hold a moment. Satan spoke of other universes. What do you know about them?"

Marie keeps her back turned to me, but I get the distinct impression she's gone pale in the face. Her breathing becomes labored. "Nothing of interest, Jason. Some questions are better left unanswered. Let's just say I'm glad that despite your genocidal tendencies, you're a good guy in this universe. It's... it's not always the case."

She's being cryptic. I open my mouth to ask another question, but her hand quickly reaches down and slaps a button on her belt. "Uh, toodles!"

Bam. She vanishes in an instant flash of light.

Teleportation, huh? She always has an escape planned out. She's probably being very careful after the manner in which I killed her original... or clone... or whatever.

I teleport a few miles back to where Sensei's body is. Carefully, I pick him up, grimacing at his headless corpse. I try to heal him, but I can't make the body look serviceable. The other clones will have to deal with this.

Return.

* * *

I arrive back in Heaven, just in front of the Mothership as it rests on the blue grass. Immediately, I feel as though something is wrong. Something is very wrong indeed.

A woman sees me and approaches slowly, hesitantly. "You... you're the original, right? The one who created the... the clones?"

I don't recognize her at all. "Yes. I'm Jason Hiro. Who are you?"

She doesn't smile at all. In fact, she looks like she's on the verge of bursting into tears. "My name is... it's Beverly Cruz. I'm the chief medical officer aboard the U.S.S. Stonewall. We were on a trip to locate the planet Revival..."

I stop her there. "Right. Hawkeye's mission. What's wrong?"

At the mention of his name, tears start flooding from her eyes. "You don't know? You don't know?! Oh god... it was awful... all the clones, they started falling over. They collapsed. I've never seen anything like it, in all my time as a doctor. They're all dead. All of them... even Hawkeye."

The news shakes me to my core. She glances down and realizes I'm carrying a headless body. "That- that body... it's..."

"A clone. A clone of mine. It's a clone of mine." My mouth opens and closes, and words come out, but I can't quite make out what I'm saying.

Slowly, I put Sensei's body on the ground and rise up.

Locate. Locate. Locate.

I aim my mind at the most memorable clones I can think of, and every time, I receive a blank in response. None of them are alive. Jesus Christ. They're all dead? How?!

Then it dawns on me. *Satan.*

He did this. That cowardly... son of a bitch! THAT SON OF A BITCH!

He must have used exterminate, or genocide, or something else like that, and killed all of my clones at once. Perhaps he didn't kill me because he couldn't... or maybe this was what he meant. He said he would win no matter what...

That... bastard. I can't... this isn't happening...

I fall to my knees and feel a weakness flow in my blood like never before. I don't want to stand. I want Amelia. I want my friends back. I want to go back to simpler days. I don't want to be a hero anymore. I'm not strong... I'm weak. I can't take it anymore.

Even as I wallow in self pity, there's a sound at the top of the ramp. I slowly raise my head to see an angel hurrying down, her eyes locked on me. "Jason! Jason! Oh god, where have you been?"

"Helen? What's wrong?" I suddenly remember I have to tell her about what happened with Amelia. She's not going to like this.

"It's Harold! He hasn't responded to me for over an hour! I can usually communicate with him with my mind, but now he won't answer and he's locked the door to his room!"

She's on the verge of panicking. I am too.

I put my hand on her shoulder. "Let's go see him together, then."

Not Harold. Not Harold. Please, Satan, please don't be this cruel. Helen is an old woman. She can't take losing her husband a second time.

We teleport inside immediately, and arrive in Harold's container room. All the lights are off, except for the light produced by his orb.

"Harold? Harold?!" Helen shrieks at the orb, but I pull her down, even as I get a mouthful of her feathered wings beating in my face in protest.

I push past her and place my hand on the orb.

Nothing. My heart is pounding fast. Where the hell is Harold?

Finally, a voice bubbles up, as if speaking from under the surface of a lake.

Who are you? Where am I?

This... this voice. It's familiar... yet alien. I've heard this voice before, long ago.

"H-Hoarhiim?"

Part 384a:

"Hoarhiim, is that really you?"

I lean forward and touch the orb more gingerly. It feels warmer than usual, or perhaps that's just my imagination. The darkness of the room seems to make the brightness of the orb that much more painful to look directly at, yet I feel somehow as if the orb is brighter than it was the last time I saw it and more full of energy.

" I know not who I am. Who am I speaking with? "

The deep voice, full of implied sagely knowledge, carries a lot more weight to it than I can remember.

"My name is Jason Hiro. You and I have met before, though that was in a future that hasn't yet come to pass. Do you remember anything at all?"

Hoarhiim's voice takes several moments to reply, and when he does, I begin to feel a familiar sensation as his face finally appears in my mind. However, the mental image of his face is blurry and indistinct. It's as if I'm looking at his face through several layers of paned glass, all fogged up by an intense cold.

" Why have you put me here? I do not like this place. "

I can't help but raise an eyebrow. "I didn't put you inside the orb. In fact, I honestly don't know how you appeared in there."

Well, *sort of*. If Hoarhiim is a dragon word, and specifically a title, not a name... then if his appearance coincides with Leviathan's death, he must be related to Leviathan somehow. Could Leviathan's soul have been trapped inside this orb when he died? But if that were the case... where is Harold?

Is Harold... gone?

I glance over at Helen. Between the light from the orb and the glow from my body, I can just barely make out a look of fascinated horror on her face. She seems to be having similar thoughts to me.

Hoarhiim interrupts my musings. *" Orb? You speak in riddles, old man. This place is a battlefield. The bodies are stacked five layers high, with many fresh wounds and many ancient ones. The bodies range from fresh to long since dessicated. Why have you trapped me in this hell? Am I the next to die? "*

Now I'm really confused. My first reaction is complete cognitive dissonance, and a moment later I come to a strange realization; the place he is describing is a place that Arthur took me to on many occasions in order to train me. Arthur told me the place was created from my own guilt, a place where I secretly mourned over those I had killed.

But why would Hoarhiim be inside of *there*?

"I don't know why you are there, Hoarhiim. Listen, that place is not real. In the real world, you are an orb of light, shining brilliantly like a miniature star. I am a human, as is the woman beside me. The orb you are in appears to be one that traps souls of the deceased, so presumably you are someone or something which has passed away recently."

" *I see.* " He takes a deep breath and sighs slowly, as if he's already come to terms with the situation. " *Is it possible for me to leave this place?* "

I quickly use my telekinesis to reactivate the lights in the room, and I glance over at a robotic body I created, long ago. It still sits, bolted to the wall, ready for me to use whenever I wish. I created it in the hopes of transferring Harold's mind, yet the old geezer denied me because he liked being in the orb or... something. I've forgotten the reason why. It's a bland thing, with no actual face to speak of, and it's made of a material that resembles smooth white plastic, but the goal was always just to make something functional and then reshape it if the transfer worked correctly.

What if I were to transfer Hoarhiim into it? Would that be possible?

If I transferred him, then he would no longer be in the orb, thus changing the future. Of course, as I have seen time and time again, the future always seems to repair itself, so if I were to try it, I would likely fail... but...

"It might be possible, Hoarhiim. If you are willing, I might be able to make use of a backup plan. I cannot guarantee it will work though, so I'd like for you to keep your expectations in check."

Finally, Helen speaks up. "Jason, where is Harold? You keep talking to this strange young man, but where is my husband during all of this?"

She doesn't seem panicked, as if I have complete control over the situation. In fact, I have no idea what's going on. This is far outside my realm of knowledge. I doubt even the Crown of Solomon would help me right now.

"I don't know, Helen. We might have to assume the worst. Please prepare yourself."

She shakes her head slowly. "Harold survived death once already, Jason. You'll find he's quite the stubborn bastard. Besides, haven't you noticed yet? This man's voice sounds similar to

Harold's."

Huh? Now that she mentions in, Hoarhiim does sound a bit like the old man. I wasn't really paying attention because their manner of speaking is so different, but the tone and timbre of their voices does sound somewhat similar...

Hoarhiim speaks again. "What must I do to leave this place?"

I scratch my head nervously. I'm not sure if I should try this or not, but it was always something I wanted to do. If it works, that would truly be a measurable change in the future. I've gotten my hopes up and had them dashed so many times now, but just once I'd like for something to go the right way.

Helen glances over and notices the robotic body and it seems to dawn on her what I'm going to do. "Is that going to work?"

"I don't know, Helen. I only ever had theories about it. It might though. Just... don't get your hopes up."

She shakes her head sadly. "When you've lived through The Great Depression, hope is a commodity in short supply, young man."

Jeez, she still calls me young. I'm hundreds of years old, you know...

I aim my mind at the robot body and the orb, trying to focus on Hoarhiim's presence inside the orb. After a few moments, I feel as if I have a good lock on him. "Brace yourself, Hoarhiim."

"I will try."

Fantastic. He sounds like such an optimist. " **Transfer!** "

I speak the word and feel a small amount of energy leave my body. A moment later, the orb dims visibly and the re-energizes. "Hoarhiim? Did it work?"

No response. His face is gone from my mental vision.

Helen and I both take slow breaths, each of us glancing at each other, then to the orb, then the robot, and back to each other again. Neither of us wants to say anything.

Finally, after what seems like an eternity, a face congeals in my mind, projected from the orb once more. It's Hoarhiim. " *Did your project work?* "

I lower my eyes slightly. "No. I'm sorry. You'll have to stay there for now."

His face seems a bit more crisp than before, and his own look of sadness passes. " *Ah. Well, such is life. I will have to deal with this tortured existence. At least you tried.* "

"Yeah... at least I tried..." I echo his words, but guilt fills my head. Did I really try? Nothing happened at all. Wordsmithing once seemed almost godlike, yet lately all I seem to do is ram

barriers. For a heroic ability that allows me to make any word reality, this power often seems so useless.

"Jason. Did you see that?" Helen pokes me, nudging me away from my dark thoughts. "I think the robot just moved."

Huh? Did it? I wasn't paying attention. I turn to watch the robot. After half a minute, nothing happens. "Are you sure you're not seeing things?"

"Jason, I'm old, not senile. I distinctly saw a finger move. I'm not hallucinating." She scolds me and I blush in response. I wasn't trying to be rude...

Suddenly I see it too. The right index finger on the robot twitches. An electrical impulse misfire, maybe? Can't be getting my hopes up... just because it moved slightly doesn't mean- ah! It moved again!

The hand twitches once more, and soon the other hand does too, as if something is trying to get a feel for the body. Both of us stare wide-eyed in fascination at the machine, and soon the hands are clenching and unclenching, and the head tilts up and down slightly. Finally, a strange electronic voice speaks, but the words are garbled.

"Glorm forgle zzzng parrrrrn fulf."

The mouth isn't designed to move on the robot, so the voice is created using electronic sounds. However, with some reworks...

" Alter. "

I quickly shift the makeup of the robot to make it look a bit more human, giving it a rubbery skin that looks like normal flesh, and allowing the mouth to move properly. "Is someone in there? Hoarhiim?"

The Hoarhiim in the orb appears in my mind's eye and watches the robot with fascination.

The robot suddenly hums to life and yelps loudly. "Shiet! What the hay? Where th' great heck am I? Jason? That you?"

Helen and I both feel relief flood us the instant we hear the voice, but Helen is the first to respond. "Harold?! Is that really you?"

"Damn straight it is, woman! I done took a nap 'n woke up, now ya'll got me chained up like some kind o' animal!"

Helen and I both break into huge grins as I release the robot body from the restraints on the wall that kept it standing. Harold doesn't even stumble forwards, instead standing up perfectly straight as if he was born to live in this body.

"Harold... we were worried, old timer. Thank god you pulled through for us."

Harold smiles at me in a way that only a robot can do. "Dumbass! Ain't nothin' that can keep an old hog like me down! Now where's that pretty lass of yours? I been wantin' ta' give her a squeeze since I first laid eyes on her!"

My smile immediately fades away. "Oh. Amelia. Listen, Harold... Helen... a lot has happened. I haven't had time to tell you yet, but might as well go over it now."

Both of them seem to immediately realize something went wrong, but even as I explain things, Harold never once stops smiling.

"Nothin' to it, my boy! She ain't dead, she still loves ya! She's jes' lyin' to herself. She's hurt, and when she recovers from th' pain, she'll be back! Women are always like that!"

Helen manages a smile. "Listen to him, Jason. He knows women pretty well. Had three sisters and two grandmothers growing up. Amelia is in pain, but I can't see her just abandoning us. Give her time and space."

I chuckle to myself. "Time, huh? I guess a hundred million years leaves a lot of time for things to change. You're probably right."

Still, if Amelia were ever to get back together with me, does it make any sense that she wouldn't know who I was in the future? Was she pretending not to know me? Maybe after a hundred million years she forgot about me entirely. Hell, that makes plenty of sense. Leviathan told me once that Amelia has a bad memory... but that was because he was feeding off her energy and draining her mental capabilities.

Leviathan... I steal a glance back at Hoarhiim's orb. Is it possible? Is the being inside the orb the same as the dragon from before? Why is he saying that he lives among a field of bodies? I don't get it.

Time travel makes no goddamn sense.

I start to turn and walk out of the room, leaving Harold and Helen to themselves, but suddenly I realize something.

"Harold. Am I remembering correctly, or didn't I use to store that cryopod of mine in here? The one with the... 'other me' in it?"

Harold frowns at me weirdly. "Err, yeah? 's always been right there." He points at an empty spot off to the far corner of the room.

I feel my hands start to tremble slightly. "Where did it go, then?"

He simply shrugs. "Dunno. Thought you moved it. Didn't even notice it was gone, ta' be honest."

Part 385a: Route A Finale

Mulgris and the other Sentinels continued to stand still, running millions of calculations in their minds as they had been doing for the last few hours. The pitch blackness around them was no barrier to their vision, given they did not perceive the universe in the same way as an organic would.

"Have we confirmed our position yet?" Mulgris directed the question at one of its subordinates.

"Negative. The only thing we have confirmed is this appears to be a negative dimensional space. It is not a part of the universe we came from. We suspect some form of dimensional folding is involved." Kraal replied with no emotion. "However, we have had luck detecting portions of the Gatekeeper's dimension. Given more time, we will be able to break free."

"Luck does not exist."

"Affirmative. A figure of speech taken from the organics."

"An illogical one. Continue work on the transmitter."

Mulgris directed his attention to one of the other nearby Sentinels. "Voltes. Your slaughtering efficiency on the organics homeworld was 14% higher than many of the other Sentinels. How were you able to accomplish this?"

Voltes continued to stand at attention. "Unit Kraal provided me with assistance. We combined our efforts to weaken and kill the organics systematically. I suspect the other Units relied solely on themselves individually in order to focus on points."

"Noted. However, it is evident by your efficiency rating that you were using a superior method for extermination. I am promoting you to second class."

"My thanks, Highest Unit Mulgris. Someday I hope to reach your level of efficiency at extermination."

"A laudable goal. I must improve myself continually if I hope to stay ahead of the low-ranked units." Mulgris paused and tilted its head to the right. "Energy release detected. The organic Commander Unit is returning in fourteen milliseconds."

"Will we be able to destroy it this time? Its threat level was far higher than the others, and it toyed around with us."

"Potentially. I analyzed its attack patterns and relayed the information to Stealth Unit Ionis. It is fortunate that the organic Commander Unit did not detect Ionis on the surface before

sending us to this dimension."

"We have limited material to work with, but Ionis..." Voltes trailed off as the energy began to build up and a figure started to appear.

"If we cannot escape, Ionis will be the key to our release."

"Unit Mulgris. Something is abnormal about this organic's energy signature." Krall hummed in alarm. "This is not an energy signature I am familiar with."

Mulgris, deep in the buried recesses of its bionic brain, felt something it had not felt in a long time before.

Fear.

* * *

The oddly colored grass crinkles softly under my bare feet. It feels pleasant, much better than the feeling of wearing hypersuit boots.

" Collapse. "

I aim my mind at the dimension I had locked the Sentinels in. As expected, they're still there, and all are accounted for. My proxy relayed visual confirmation of their existence a moment before they attacked and killed him. It wouldn't save them, unfortunately, since he was just a really weak clone I deliberately created to make sure they were still in there.

My mind continues to perceive the dimension they're in, and a few moments later it folds in on itself to an infinitely tiny atom of existence before vanishing completely, taking the Sentinels along with it.

Satan gave me the answer, ironically. I understand now what he did... he used 'create' to form a tiny marble-sized bomb of unimaginable power. Such a weapon shouldn't exist, but it did. He created it using the power of Wordsmithing and its abilities to reshape reality as I know it. While the amount of energy needed to create such a tiny bomb with that power would be far beyond what he could produce, if he merely imagined that it came from a star or another galaxy, he could create the energy easily.

Perhaps I was wrong all along. What if Wordsmithing has no limits? Perhaps even changing the future is possible. What's the key then? What have I been missing that Satan understood?

My cryopod is gone. I can't locate it with wordsmithing, which seems to defy my perception of wordsmithing's limits. Is it limited, or is it unlimited? Why can I collapse a dimension with little effort, absorb a star, create a micro-nuke, teleport everywhere, but can't change free will?

Is this the work of the Creator? Are these merely arbitrary limits placed on me to test my ingenuity?

A more pressing question comes to mind. I absorbed a star and my abilities increased dramatically, reshaping how they function entirely. Why would merely consuming a star give me the ability to Smith without speaking? Why do I now have the ability to Thoughtsmith in addition to Wordsmithing? What changed?

Perhaps I've misunderstood how hero powers work. I remember once being told about how each successive hero becomes more powerful than the one from the previous generation. Considering the power of Wordsmithing, how much more powerful could the next hero have become? The ability to create anything with their mind? Isn't that just Thoughtsmithing but without extra steps?

I'm immortal. If I don't die, the next hero can't rise. But since the Angels created the heroes, and the Angels are nearly extinct, then does that mean I'm forever going to be the last hero?

What a burden.

Perhaps, when I absorbed the star, I forced the next hero's powers to rise up, but inside of myself. Either that or my power just mutated out of nowhere. Marie doesn't want me to know about alternate universes, but if they really do exist, there must be a universe where I died and the next hero arose. Perhaps not so much a universe, but a different timeline. Multiverse theory? I'm not a physicist, so I don't understand these things.

I sigh deeply and glance around. The bodies of my clones are being hauled around by humans in the area and lined up, sorted by the numerals and designations listed on their armor. Around 3,000 have been hauled already, but more are still coming. These are just the clones that survived fighting the Sentinels. Countless others died on Mars' surface.

Their deaths were senseless. My clones were invincible, right up until an armada of hyper-powered death robots proved that theory incorrect. Even when they survived, they had their lives stolen by a coward. Yes, stolen. That is the appropriate word to use. Satan seized the power of Wordsmithing from Sensei, and then used the power to steal the lives of my clones.

I should have been prepared. Honestly, I'll never make another clone ever again. If I'm going to get by from now on, it will be under my own power.

Storage.

I reach into the infinity of my dimensional storage and pull out the Crown of Solomon. It was always such a hassle wearing this along with my Hypersuit, but it seems I won't be able to wear

the suits anymore, they react badly with my new form. My body is surrounded in a faint aura, not unlike that of Arthur's, one that allows me to breathe in space.

Funny, I wonder how my power compares to that of Arthur, now?

I guess I'll never know.

Harold walks up behind me and pats me lightly on the back, his form looking much more human now. I took care to age him to roughly that of his wife, but he still talks like an old man.

"Whatcha thinkin' about, kid?"

I glance down at the crown in my hand for a moment before placing it on my head without ceremony. For once, I don't feel an instant rush of mental acuity as I used to. Now it's only a faint feeling.

"Nothing much, old timer. Yet, everything. It all seems so pointless in the end."

His head creaks slightly and he chuckles. "Haha! Life's a bitch, and then ye die! That's what my uncle used ta say! Good man, died in the first World War, he did."

"Sounds like he was right. No offense."

Harold's smile fades slightly. "None taken. It's been hundreds of years. Helen and you are all I got left. Rest o' my family wouldn't recognize me or know who I am. No point lookin'."

"I know that feeling." I glance up at the sky above. The way Heaven is illuminated feels so artificial, given it has no star. It's not even a real planet. "My parents died when I was young. I was raised in an orphanage. Barely remember it."

"Yer last name's Japanese. Wha's going on with that?"

He asks it casually but I still feel bothered. "Nothing, really. I think my father was Japanese, met my mom while he was in America. I don't even have a picture of them, only know what the social worker told me. The orphanage wasn't a high class one, so adoptions pretty much never happened. Government grant got me into college at 16... I failed out of it."

Harold shouldn't even be interested in my childhood. It's boring. Until I made the decision to cryofreeze myself, my life had nothing going for it.

And look at me now. I've destroyed a bunch of planets, killed trillions of sentient beings, failed at preventing the extermination of a species, and directly caused the near extinction of two others. Not to mention I've destroyed at least three star systems.

If I'm a hero, what is a villain?

Harold clears his throat, which seems odd given he's in a robotic body. Maybe it's just involuntary, since he used to be a human. "I had cancer, ya know. Also a lot of brain issues

'cause of the mustard gas in the first world war. Died, ended up inside an orb, and now I'm in a robot body. Ain't never asked for nothin' in mah life. Always just wanted the right ta' fight for mah country, make sure mah wife lived a good life. Way I see it, everything in the universe is pointless. We're all gonna die anyway, son. Don't beat yourself up over failures, a'ight? Can't learn unless ya screw up."

I finally feel a smile spread across my face. "I screw up a lot."

"Means ya learned a lot." Harold pats me on the back again and turns to walk away. "Long as ya got the power to change reality with a single word, ain't no such thing as a failure. You'll figger it out, son."

At least someone has faith in me.

We part ways without another word, and I aim my mind at Mars. I have a lot of work ahead of me.

Return.

* * *

The shadow shifted around the room, moving without needing to use his legs. In the pure darkness of his underground lair, the shadows might as well be a dream come true. It took no energy to move around inside of something he understood on a level no other being could possibly hope to.

But he was uneasy.

"You don't know your name?"

The face that projected itself from the orb before him was foreign, completely alien. Valac hadn't spoken in hours. Instead, it was as if he had undertaken a complete transformation into a new person. More likely, something had happened and Valac was gone.

Whatever the thing was inside of the orb, it made Valac look like an imp. The power emanating from the orb was incomparable to its previous levels. It was a tenfold- no, a hundred-fold increase.

"A name? What use would I have for a name?" The voice that spoke from the orb was filled with inescapable rage, yet completely serene. It held unspoken memories of pain and betrayal, yet also hoped for a better future, one where all bowed before its crushing might.

"I don't know. You aren't Valac, so you must be someone else. Who are you?"

"I have no memory. I did not exist, and then I did."

Yama slithered around in the darkness absentmindedly as he contemplated what this might mean. "I suppose I could simply refer to you as Darkness. I can't just keep calling you Black Orb."

"Names have no value to me." The empty face blinked long and hard. "Why am I trapped in this vessel? Did you put me here?"

Yama wasn't one to show much emotion these days, but the question made him snicker. "A humorous thought. Your power exceeds mine by a terrifying factor. How you arrived in that orb is a total mystery."

Hehe... maybe. Yama kept that thought to himself. *Satan was killed, I felt his link to the threads sever. Could he have ended up inside the orb? Valac remembered his identity though, so why wouldn't Satan? Perhaps this being is unrelated. His power certainly exceeds anything Satan could have hoped for.*

"Ah. A word has appeared in my mind." The thing inside the orb spoke up, its voice expressing a feeling of joy. "Blaarjiim. Yes, that is my name."

Yama crinkled up his face, as best as he could, given his body was made of black smoke. "Blaarjiim? What sort of name is that? No demon I know has a name remotely similar."

Blaarjiim shook his head slowly in Yama's mind's eye. "The word appeared in my memory. I have heard it somewhere. It feels... right. Are you questioning my judgment?"

His question held an edge of malice. Yama immediately backed down. "No, no, of course not. Blaarjiim it is, then. Valac was aiding me in my quest to eradicate the humans... will you do the same?"

"What are humans?" Blaarjiim's menacing voice held an edge of curiosity to it.

"Disgusting creatures. They seek to eradicate the lives of demons, such as myself. They hate us without reason and wish to do us harm. Still... there are good humans." Yama's voice trailed off for a moment as his mind wandered for a moment.

He quickly brought himself back on topic. "Still, exceptions are not the rule."

"Very well. I have nothing else to do, so if you need my power, I will give it freely." Blaarjiim flicked his head away and seemed to stare off at nothing in particular. "This place is dreadfully boring."

"I concur." Yama took a few steps forward and picked up the orb from its metallic holder. "I will show you the universe you have arrived in. Perhaps we will find answers to who you are and where Valac has gone to."

Blaarjiim hesitated. "This Valac... was he someone important to you?"

"Not in the slightest. I'm just curious as to where he went. In due time, I'm sure the answers will appear."

"Lead the way."

* * *

Diablo stood closely, yet not too close. He wasn't particularly fond of Belial, but the hollow look in her eyes made even a devil like himself feel a certain amount of sadness. No man liked to see a woman cry, even if she was trying to be strong for everyone around her.

The new labyrinth was excellent, as Satan had made sure of. The shifting hallways were a rather uncanny touch, though Diablo was unsure where the First Emperor had gotten the idea.

The small viewing area the two demons stood in now was a quaint one, nothing to write home about, but there were some plants in the center of the room, and even a few flowers as well. The place smelled nice, though the low lighting due to only being able to use torches gave the area a creepy vibe. Soon the demon's palace would be finished and all of the high-ranking generals would have a truly exquisite place to live in.

Diablo, along with Bael and several others, were looking forward to that.

But... Belial didn't care about any of it in the slightest. "He really did die, in the end."

Marie, sitting on a bench nearby, puffed on her cigarette. "You know, if you loved him so much, why weren't you there? There wasn't anything you could have done against Jason, but at least you would feel a little less guilty about not helping."

Diablo scowled at the human. "That is uncalled for."

Belial shook her head. "No, Marie is right. I should have been there with him. I could have at least held him in his final moments. He would have liked that."

Marie quickly pulled the cigarette out of her mouth and choked as she stifled a laugh. "Haha! Oh gods, that's a good one! You know what he would really have liked? Not dying! Now he's just a corpse laying on a barren patch of ground somewhere."

Diablo glared viciously at her. "Enough! I will not allow you to speak of the former First Emperor in such a foul manner! Belial is grieving right now!"

"Grieving, schmieving. Jason told Belial about the future and she knew Satan was going to die. This fake sadness and shock is disgusting. It's a sign of weakness. It would be better to honor his memory by taking revenge against Jason Hiro, though after what I've seen, it's not possible anymore."

Diablo looked as if his top was about to blow, but Marie's eyes closed and she lowered her voice. "Forget Jason for a moment. The real trouble was that girlfriend of his. Jason told me he hasn't a chance of beating her as she is right now, and she was the one who killed Satan. She's extremely powerful and very dangerous."

Belial blinked and wiped at her eyes as she collected herself, adjusting the straps on her skimpy outfit. "Right, Amelia. So she had the soul of Leviathan inside of her? I never expected that. You're lucky they let you leave."

"Yeah. Lucky." Marie smiled weakly and took another drag from her cigarette. "Not exactly the word I'd use."

"It seems to me that Jason made a calculated risk by letting you go." Diablo stepped away from Belial, feeling slightly confident that she wasn't about to burst into tears again. He walked over and sat down on the opposite side of the bench Marie was sitting on. "I can't see why he'd do that."

Marie rolled her eyes slyly. "I fed him a line and he believed it. Tricking the minds of my inferiors is a simple task."

"Are we your inferiors too?" Belial sat down on the ground, wondering how a substance made of pseudo-dirt could feel so hard, and yet so soft.

"Naturally. Everyone is. It makes finding good conversation a real challenge."

"You poor thing." Diablo let the comment slip and chuckled to himself a moment later. "If only we all had your problems."

For half a minute, nobody said anything else. The feeling in the air grew more and more awkward until finally Marie tossed the finished cigarette down and stamped it out. "I'm heading to my lab. Until the primary facility is re-established under Earth's surface, I'll be in the backup one. You know where to find me."

She stood up and walked a few feet away, pausing only to fiddle with her belt before vanishing in a flash of light.

Belial blinked several times. "She loves her dramatic exits."

"And I love my entrances."

A voice suddenly spoke out, making both demons freeze and look around.

Belial's heart fluttered slightly. "That voice!" She quickly jumped to her feet. "Satan?!"

Invisible arms reached from the darkness from behind her and wrapped around her front, caressing her tender parts. A moment later, Satan's body suddenly appeared and he kissed her

ear tenderly. "Sorry I made you cry, darling. I've been busy."

She let his hands rove for a moment before pushing away and spinning to stare at him, her confusion only increasing even more. His entire body glowed a strange, yellowish color. It was as if energy radiated from every pore, illuminating him like a lightbulb.

"Y-you're glowing!"

He shrugged nonchalantly and smiled. "A lot has happened."

Diablo stood up slowly from his seat and walked over with caution. "Are you really... Satan? You look different."

"Of course I am, Diablo. I faked my death."

Satan's statement was so matter-of-fact, it made Belial and Diablo suspicious instantly. She was the first to counter. "How? Explain."

"Can't you just be happy that I'm back? Ah, it's fine. You are a curious female, after all." Satan glanced around the room. "It's rather dark in here, though. Let's make it less gloomy."

A moment later, the entire room brightened dramatically, making the two weaker demons wince. It was as if a false star was in the sky, though nothing was there. The light came from nowhere, and yet everywhere at once.

"That will do." Satan reached over and put his arm around Belial's shoulder. "Let's have a seat while I explain what happened."

And so he did. After a few minutes, he had explained his genius plan for stealing the power of wordsmithing.

"Once I had Jason's power, the rest was simple. I was still in Zeus' Hypertime, so I created a clone. I then teleported away and my clone took over. If the clone could defeat Jason, that would be excellent. If not, I would fake my own death. What I and my clone did not expect was the woman named Amelia... she was holding Leviathan inside of her."

Satan shook his head. "Tsk ts. Luckily my clone did his job well, as I knew he would. He played the whole thing off well. They never saw it coming."

Belial blushed and smiled sweetly. "I'm just glad you're alive. I really... thought..."

Diablo looked away and felt slightly bashful as he heard Satan kiss his concubine tenderly.

"I would never leave you alone, Lilia. Well, at least... not before." Satan's voice suddenly caught in his throat and he coughed to clear it. "Things have, unfortunately, changed."

"What do you mean?" Diablo's interest was piqued.

"I have analyzed how the future might proceed. Without a doubt, until the moment Jason went back in time, I had not been seen or heard from in 100 million years. Belial genuinely thought I was dead. Therefore, by revealing myself, the future will have to make sure I am eliminated."

Satan reluctantly pulled away from Belial and stood up. "Time is a fickle thing. In truth, this doesn't mean I must die. Instead, I simply must appear to be dead to everyone, right up until the moment Jason goes back in time. After that, the future will be mine to rewrite."

Belial and Diablo shot a look at each other and shrugged, unable to parse exactly what he meant. This theoretical stuff sounded an awful lot like human technology and concepts, something the average demon simply couldn't understand.

Satan noticed and decided to take a different approach. "Let's make this simple. I'm going to erase any memory of our conversation here. You won't remember I am alive. Nobody will. However, since you will likely be intimate with Jason in the future, I'll make sure-

Belial immediately interrupted. "Not a chance! I'm not losing you a second time, and certainly never going to get close to that... that human! He disgusts me! He's vile!"

Satan sighed and lightly brushed her arm with his hand. "Lilia... come, now. Don't be that way. As I was about to say, you didn't know who he was the first time you met him in the future... therefore, something must have happened to erase your memory."

She frowned. "Erased my memory? What do you mean?"

Satan tapped his lip. "I wonder that myself. It's possible in the original timestream, the one Jason came from, you genuinely never had met him. However, this timestream is doing everything it can to repair itself... so naturally..." His voice trailed off as he thought about it. "Well, he's probably going to erase everyone's memory."

Diablo raised an eyebrow. "He can do that?"

"Easily. Wordsmithing is a powerful ability, to say the least." Satan stared into the eyes of his beloved. "But I won't allow him to. Instead, I will wipe everyone's memories of Jason. In addition, I'm going to set a trap for him, one he'll never anticipate."

Belial pulled close and wrapped her arms around Satan again, burying her face in his chest. "What trap, love?"

"On top of erasing your memory of me, and every being's memory of Jason Hiro... I'm going to hypnotize you specifically, Lilia."

"For what purpose?" Diablo leaned in a little closer as he spotted a glint in Satan's eye.

"Jason will grow to trust Lilia in the far future. We will ensure that trust is certain to be a knife in his back at the most inopportune moment."

Belial stared up into her lover's cruel, cold gaze, her own eyes filled with stars.

"Oh Satan, you're such a cruel bastard sometimes."

"You wouldn't have it any other way." Satan tittered to himself as his hands roved over her body. "Before we do all of that and have to separate for a hundred million years... we should enjoy our last bit of time together. Let's have a honeymoon."

She blushed madly. "You really know how to sweep a woman off her feet."

Chapter 3 – Route B

Part 386b: Reawakening

I'M AWAKE!

My eyes flip open, and my arms jerk forward involuntarily, only to smack into an invisible wall. A few seconds later, I finally register the feeling of pain and wince.

That hurt.

It's pitch black all around me, but as I begin to wake up and shift my body, I become acutely aware of how cold I am. I feel like I took a dip in the Antarctic ocean.

There is a hissing sound in front of me, and I perceive something lifting up. Wait, is this... oh right, it's the cryopod. I remember now.

It was just a few minutes ago; I was in the room with the other cryopod participants. We were part of an experiment from CryoTek... but this is...

I stare numbly as the hatch to my pod lifts up. The light above me is shifting off and on, and it's getting dimmer every second. The room all around me is totally pitch black.

Finally, as the lid stops lifting up, the light brightens, and I can see the room around me.

It looks familiar... Have I been here before?

There are four pillars in the center of the room. I feel like I've seen them before.

I step forward, carefully lifting my foot up, so I don't trip over the lower lip of my cryopod. Walking forward, I note that the pillars are covered in strange runes. Even more strangely, I can read them. They look Japanese, but to my eyes, they appear as ordinary as plain English.

Death is coming.

Good lord, that's ominous. Yet, it doesn't seem to affect my mood negatively, which is odd. I'm feeling too calm about all of this. I turn back to look around the room. There's a single door that appears to lead out. I start to step towards the door, but I pause.

Flashlight. I need a flashlight.

I walk back around to the pod's rear side, and without a second thought, I pop open a back hatch, I instantly spot a flashlight, some rope, an old rusted gun, and some nasty looking cans of gunk. I leave everything there but the flashlight. I get this strange feeling that I won't need any of the rest of it.

I walk up to the door and spot even more strange symbols, all of which I can read effortlessly.

Never leave.

Hmm. I don't like being told what to do, so I'll just ignore the warning. I push against the door with all of my strength, and it slowly opens with a scraping sound. A wave of air surges into the room and I take a deep breath, realizing I had been feeling oxygen starved. I crank up my flashlight and aim it forwards.

There's a freaky looking statue there, but for some reason... I'm not scared. I've seen this figure before. Its beady eyes seem to follow me around as I walk around it.

No... no, that's not right. They *are* following me around.

"You... what are you? I've seen you before."

The statue moves, which almost makes me jerk back, but I hold my ground.

"Hmm? You were able to tell I was real?"

The statue speaks, its voice a nasty sounding noise, resembling when you take off and put the lid back on one of those hollow metal garbage cans.

"Yes... why do I recognize you? I'm staring a monstrosity in the face, yet I feel no fear."

The statue cackled quietly under its breath. "Hehehe.... you should be proud of yourself. A mere human, addressing the mighty Gressil. You will die soon, of course, whether I kill you or don't."

I nodded quietly. "Hm. I suppose so. However..."

I get this odd feeling in my mind. "I feel like... somehow... you're already dead."

The statue monster, Gressil, he narrows his beady eyes and glares at me. "Human... are you mocking me?"

I shrug. "I don't think so. However, I have the distinct impression that with the power of just one word, I can defeat you."

Gressil laughs. "One word?! Oh by the seven devils, I have to hear this one!"

I nod. "Alright, fair enough. *Die.* "

His body freezes, as it slowly starts to shake. "W-what... what are... you...?!" A few moments later, he keels over on the floor in a comically dramatic fashion, dead.

Why did I do that? How did I know to do that?

As I look down at his body, I note other runes on the ground, but I ignore them. They don't seem important to me.

There's something else, drawing me into the next room. Something... important. I can't place my finger on it, but it's definitely life-shattering.

I press open the door, as I enter the next room. It's a long, wide hallway. I've certainly seen it before. These memories feel like whispers from a fogged up mirror, slowly seeping into my mind.

I calmly walk down the hallway, and after almost a half hour, I've traveled what feels like two or three miles. It's a long, straight hallway, with darkness all around me. I can barely make out the walls, and the ceiling is just *barely* there, but the end of the hallway is far beyond the distance I can see.

Finally, I arrive at the end of the hall. I end up seeing three doors. A small one on the left, a *very* large one in the middle, and another small one on the right. Those two small doors have the same writing on them, and I can read it as if it was plain English.

The door on the left says... "Prey".

The door on the right says... "Safety".

Well, I'm no genius, but I like the sound of 'safety' far more than I do 'prey'. I decide to enter the door on my right. I still have that strange feeling, like I've been here before.

I'm pleasantly surprised to see that the entire hallway, as I enter through the door, is illuminated by torches. Another immediate feeling reaches me, which is that I have to ask a simple question... *Who lit them?* My stomach cringes a little bit as I walk down the hallway. After about fifteen paces, I suddenly hear a *boom* behind me, as the door I entered through slams shut.

Wonderful. I'm so excited I could just cry.

As I walk down the hallway, I notice that the end of it seems to be unlit, and there's a darkness coming from it.

A deep gloom, actually. It seems to swallow up the light coming from the torches. As I look into it, I mentally rewrite all the feelings of ominousness that I had the whole way here. This is greatly intimidating, but I don't have any chance other than to keep walking forward.

Yet, somehow, the thought of darkness doesn't seem to scare me at all. I arrive at it, and enter through it, stepping into a pitch black void. I... can't see anything. I can't even see my own hand or the light around me.

As I walk forward, the darkness seems to disappear slowly, fading into mist. Finally, I arrive at a strange stone altar, one I can just barely make out in the receding darkness. There appears to be an ominous, pitch black orb set there... it's resting on the podium all by itself. There

appears to be a statue against the rear wall, resembling an angel, wings spread wide open, her hands upraised into the air. Her head is aimed upwards, as if she's a fallen angel, begging for forgiveness for her misdeeds. It's... hauntingly beautiful.

But that black orb, resting atop the plain altar... it draws my vision towards it enticingly.

As I stare at it, a voice whispers in the back of my mind. " *Hello, mortal. Do you desire the power to rule over life and death?* "

Wow. That's one heck of an opening question. "I'm not sure... are you offering it to me?"

"Hehehehe..." The voice becomes more distinct, as a mental face of a man cloaked in shadow appears in my mind. "Not many ask questions before they accept my power."

"Your power huh? I don't recall you answering the question."

The face inside my mind grimaces slightly. "You're an interesting one. If you should pick me up and accept my power, I will help you eliminate all who oppose you."

Hmm. Sounds too good to be true. "How do I know I can trust you?"

As the face in my mind suspiciously licks his lips, I find myself thinking that even this is all too familiar, yet... different. I feel as if an unseen path has diverged.

"You don't know. But I sense inside you a great, terrible darkness. You *know* you wish to have my power, do you not?"

I find myself nodding imperceptibly. "Perhaps... perhaps not. What happens if I accept your power?"

The orb starts to speak again, but from behind me, I hear a scratching sound. It's the sound of something moving quietly, but rubbing itself against a wall as it walks.

I slowly tilt my head back towards the direction of the sound. There, I see something that... it should frighten me, but once again, it does not. It appears to be a living thing, a creature, perhaps even a monster, made entirely of shadow.

As I stare at it, it does not move. I decide to take the initiative. "Who are you?"

The shadow seems to rustle slightly, as its body shifts and it appears to look at me. " **I am the servant of this place, the keeper of the secret darkness. Why do you not fear me?** "

I shrug slightly. "For some reason, little seems to scare me right now. I'm... unnaturally calm. I feel as if I have done this already."

The creature stares wordlessly for a moment or two. " **Perhaps you have. Perhaps you have not. This place is filled with many secrets, lies, and deceptions. You should**

trust the one before you. Here, in this place, might makes right, and strength guarantees you will succeed at all endeavors. "

I nod slowly. "I suppose that may be true." I turn back to the black orb in front of me. "You appear to have a personality and a mind of your own. Do you also possess a name?"

The being inside the orb grins inside my mind. "Such manners. I am known as Blaarjiim, the King of Darkness. It is a pleasure to make your acquaintance."

I pick the orb off the altar and heft it into one hand. I can feel a dark power enter into my body even as I do this. "A pleasure to meet yours as well. I am Jason Hiro."

The shadow monster moves forward noiselessly, melting from one patch of darkness to the next until he is suddenly beside me. I can't help but notice that he's a tiny little fellow, only four feet tall, perhaps a bit bigger than that. Compared to my six-foot stature, he's a midget.

"We are aware of your name, young Hiro. I am Yama, the acolyte of darkness. I stood guard over the container that held you for... a long time. However, even I did not expect the turn of events that led to Gressil's death." His voice is deep, but coming from his little body, it almost feels comical. It's like he's compensating for something.

"Gressil is dead?" Blaarjiim speaks again, confusion evident in his voice. Apparently, the shadow monster didn't tell him about this. "How is that possible? In order for Jason to do that, he would have to-"

"In due time." Yama cuts off the demonic being in my mind as if to prevent him from speaking. "Jason has not yet... realized the situation he is in. Or perhaps he has...?" His eyes are tough to tell apart from the rest of his body, but still, I feel as if he stares up at me questioningly.

I shake my head slowly. "Afraid not. I'm mystified. You guys are monsters of some sort... so something went horribly wrong and I must have died in the cryopod. I think I'm in Hell."

Yama snickers quietly. "An apt description, human. Amusingly, you are correct. This is, in fact, Hell."

Oh. He says it so casually. I merely nod along. "Great. Thanks for letting me know. So if I'm dead, then that means this place is a punishment for my crimes? I don't remember doing anything wrong."

"Nay, it is not Hell in the sense one who hails from the Source would think of it, but Hell as in the name of this realm." Blaarjiim thoughtfully corrects me. "You are in the Great Labyrinth, a realm of mystery and unexplored secrets. Demons roam the halls, and as a human, you are sure to be short on allies."

Something about Blaarjiim's words appear to be... false. Maybe it's the tone of his voice or something, but I feel as if he's lying to me.

"Are there no other humans here?"

His face forms an expression of disgust in my mind. "Quite the contrary. Demons have been... losing the war. Humans overrun this place, but they are the worst scum of all. Turn your back on a demon, and you are likely to get stabbed. Turn your back on a human, and..." His voice trails off.

Yama finishes. "Don't turn your back on a human. Make no deals with a human. Humans are perverse monsters, though they label us as such. They seek the extermination of any who do not look like them."

I can't help but glare from the orb to the shadow monster and back to the orb again. "I'm a human. You're saying you don't trust me, then?"

"Certainly not." Yama curls up his lip. "Gressil is proof of that."

Err, he makes a good point. I did kill that statue monster without any effort. Come to think of it, how *did* I kill it?

Blaarjiim seems to read my mind. "Your killing of Gressil was quite impressive. With my power added to your own, you will be quite helpful for retaking our land from the humans."

"Aren't you curious about how I did it?"

I ask the question and immediately both monsters chortle at me.

Yama stops snickering and manages to form a response. "How arrogant. We already know, of course. The power of Wordsmithing is quite... pervasive. In fact, I will be the one to teach you how to use it properly, since I know far more about it than you do."

Wordsmithing? He knows about my power and it already has a name? Aw, man. Here I thought I was unique or something.

Wait a minute. "How do you know what Wordsmithing is?"

Yama stares silently for a few moments. "I have my ways."

Cryptic. "I could kill you with a single word, demon."

Blaarjiim raises an eyebrow. "Interesting. Your attitude is... unexpected. You are an aberration among your kind."

I toss the pitch black orb into my other hand, realizing my right hand is starting to cramp up. The orb is a lot heavier than it looks. "By 'kind', you mean humans, right?"

"I mean many different things." Blaarjiim crosses his arms in my mind's eye, and I realize further questioning is pointless.

A loud growl sounds off in the cave and I realize I'm starving. "Listen, this is a good chat but... can we get some food?"

Yama shakes his head slowly. "The human need for sustenance is a foreign concept to me. Demons can intake food, but we do it solely for reasons of boredom or pleasure. In any case, I have a secret base where you will be able to fill your urges."

The wording makes me frown, but I shrug it off. Demons are odd.

"Let's go, then."

Blaarjiim stirs. "It has been a long time since I left that pedestal. Yama, why did you forsake me for so long?"

The shadow grunts to himself quietly. "It was only a hundred years. Calm thyself, King of Darkness."

With a motion of his hands, a shadow bends around Yama, making him disappear wordlessly. A moment later, the darkness races at me, making my heart slam in my chest before I feel a sensation of being washed down a tube.

When my eyes open next, I have to blink hard as torches lining the walls appear to be unbearably bright.

Yama is standing a few feet away, as he gestures down the hallway in front of me toward a room up ahead with the flame of a small fire crackling in a fireplace. "Welcome to my lair, young Hiro."

Part 387b:

The hallway is quite dark, despite the five torches on each side of the wall extending down the hall, but to eyes that were just in an unnatural darkness unlike any other, it's as if I'm staring directly into the sun. The walls themselves are tiled, and appear to be made of an onyx-like black substance, one that absorbs the light around it instead of allowing the light to bounce off its surface.

I rub the water from my eyes and sniffle slightly. "Where are we?"

"My lair." Yama barely even gives me a decent answer as we start to walk down the hallway.

"Yes, I got that. I'm asking where the lair itself is."

Yama tilts his smoking black head at me with a look that can only be described as disgusted annoyance. "To explain would be more trouble than I care to invest myself in. You are likely suffering from the freezing sickness, so we should give you sustenance first."

Freezing sickness? Ah, he must be talking about cryosleep sickness. What a weird thing to call it.

We arrive at the end of the hall and walk into a rather plain dining room. The fire I saw from before is much smaller than I thought, little more than a small pile of sticks barely burning at all. It seemed so much bigger when I first saw it.

The floor is made of black wood, with a balsamic aroma that smells quite nice. The room itself is rather empty, though I do notice several paintings of a human woman scattered all around the walls, hung at somewhat random intervals. Wearing a black outfit with long black hair, she seems sad, as if she didn't want to sit still for the painting. Why would he have pictures of a human female?

My thoughts are interrupted as four girls walk in the room. Young women really, and *human* to boot. They're dressed in rags that barely seem to be held together by strings the thickness of shoelaces. They look handwoven, as if they were made from potato sacks from the 1800's.

I'm quite surprised by the four women, but they completely ignore me, and silently fall to their knees and bow before Yama, throwing their hands out in front of them and letting their foreheads touch the floor. In fact, everything about them is silent, even the way in which they move.

Yama barely even glances at them, instead talking to the air above their bowed forms. "This one is our guest. Give him anything he wishes. Start with a meal. Something lavish, whatever it

is you humans eat will do."

They don't respond, not even nodding, before quickly standing up and walking out, never once looking directly at his face. Yama turns back to me. "In twenty minutes or so, the food will be prepared."

My mouth opens and closes, but I find it hard to put words to action. "Who were they?"

He blinks a few times, slowly. "The chattel? Hardly worth your consideration. Of course, since you are a human, if you feel the need to relieve yourself, they will be at your command. In any case, you seem quite dirty, and you're covered in residue from that container, but they will treat an honored guest such as yourself well."

Now I tap my foot and rub my lip. "So they're slaves."

Blaarjiim stirs in my hand. "Are you disturbed, because you share a kinship with them? They are subhuman, entirely different from yourself. Don't concern yourself with their lot."

Yama's eyes seem to open a bit wider. "Ah, Blaarjiim is right. Forgive me, I forgot that you might be offended seeing other members of your species reduced to such a pitiful existence."

Well... it's not that I'm offended... I suppose it makes sense demons would have human slaves...

"You mentioned back before we arrived here that demons were losing a war. If you're losing a war, why do you have human slaves? Why would you attempt to befriend me, a human, if you hate my kind?"

Yama ponders my question for a moment, but once again it is Blaarjiim who answers. "You misunderstand. We do not hate humans, we view them as inferior creatures. Do humans hate the stupid animals that roam their homeworld? Of course not. But if those beasts rose up and took over, the humans would be sure to resent their actions."

A smile crosses my face. "If humans are so inferior, then why are they winning the war?"

The living shadow immediately scowls. "I ask myself that very question all the time." With a small flourish, he snatches Blaarjiim's orb out of my hands. "The chattel will draw you up a bath. Down that hall and to the left. I have no need of such things, so the only option available will be in the servant's quarters."

I shake my head slowly and start to walk away, but Blaarjiim appears in my mind. "I can feel your doubt about our motivations, but you must understand you will have all the answers you need soon."

His words fill me with the exact opposite of confidence. "Great. I'm gonna go get cleaned up."

* * *

This place is dark and gloomy. A feeling of total despondency hangs on the air, like the smell of a thousand dead bodies. As I walk down the hall, I pass incredibly small rooms, all of which have barely enough room for tiny bunkbeds covered in filth, some of which have various slaves sleeping, and some that don't. I quickly can't help but notice the only slaves here are female. There are no men. Why? Does Yama fear men? Perhaps he's a lascivious sort of demon. Maybe it's something else.

What the hell am I doing? I killed a demon, that Gressil creature, yet Yama wants me to be his best friend now. Why shouldn't I just kill Yama too while I'm at it? Why not free these humans?

Then again, maybe they deserve it. I don't know the full story yet. What if humans are sick fuckers who do even worse things to demons. Do humans enslave demons? Do they just kill them indiscriminately? I mean, they *are* demons.

As I walk past room after room, I begin to wonder if Yama has ever set foot in this wing of his base. The bath certainly wasn't *just down the hall on the left*. I feel like I've walked a mile already, and I've passed several hallways on the right and left. This place feels like a goddamn maze. The dingy smell and dark corridors are even less illuminated than the hallways from before, though my eyes are unnaturally keen, for some reason. I can see into the darkness with startling clarity.

As I walk, I hear a soft pitter-patter of feet behind me. When I turn back, a young woman, possibly a year older or younger than me, stands silently with her head bowed.

"Huh? What is it?"

I ask a simple question, but she offers no response. She holds her right hand out hesitantly to me, making a cupping motion as if to scoop water, then she points behind herself towards a hallway I just passed. Never once does she look at me.

"You want me to go that way?"

She nods hesitantly before quickly turning and walking down the hallway she indicated before, and I waste no time in following after her.

She's a lovely thing, though it's tough to tell, what with the scraggly matted down red hair. She wears the same stitched together rags as all the other female slaves, making me wonder what the purpose is in forcing them to wear such humiliating clothing. Or then, perhaps that's the point. Humiliation. Her hair doesn't move at all, given it seems to be caked with dirt so

badly that it's almost brittle. Her arms also seem to be covered in black dust, likely soot if I had to wager a guess. She must be someone who cleans out the fireplaces and torches I've observed.

She continues walking and I follow along until we arrive at the end of a hallway which opens into a startlingly clean looking bath house. It immediately reminds me of something I saw in Japanese guidebooks before I entered the cryopod.

In fact, the resemblance is uncanny. It's as if a non-Japanese person based this bath directly on a picture from a Japanese hotel pamphlet.

The slave girl stops before the door and stands to its side, keeping her head bowed, even as her bushy red hair falls forward unnaturally to hide her face. If I didn't know any better, I'd say it was intentional.

"Thank you for... showing me the way." I scratch my head, hemming and hawing while trying to make this less awkward, but as I speak, an old woman suddenly appears from the other side of the doorway to the bath house's entrance.

"You're the visitor, eh?"

Her skin is dark red, and her face is quite hideous. It looks almost like it's sagging off her face from generations of scowling at visitors she didn't like. I can immediately tell she isn't human. Contrasted with the young woman to my side, this is quite the old broad, clearly not one to honor any notions of romanticism. Her eyes are tinged with irritation as if she's seen it all and lived a thousand lives.

"Yes. I'm Jason Hiro. Yama brought me here to-"

"I know. Devil's sake, humans are mouthy bastards." She rolls her eyes before clapping her hands so loudly the human girl flinches. "Lora! Wipe that smile off your face! Get this man clean!"

'Lora' isn't smiling. What is this old demoness talking about?

The girl shoots a glance at the pool of water and I feel as if there is a deep longing in her eyes, as if she would kill for a chance to scrub herself clean.

The old bat glares at me. "What are you waiting for? Drop the clothes and get in! Lord Yama does not like to be kept waiting!"

As she says this, Lora immediately reaches around behind herself and starts to undo the back of her shirt, all while the old woman is apparently impatient for me to do the same.

This feels wrong.

"Ah, that won't be necessary. I'll clean myself." I quickly push past the old demon even as I feel her glare blast into my back.

"Oh, I see! Too good for ya, eh?" Her grimace lightens for a moment. "Hmm, on the other hand, perhaps I misunderstood. I wouldn't want the vermin touching me either."

I start to clarify that wasn't my intention, only to see Lora's eyes staring at the pool of water sadly. I suddenly realize that she probably doesn't care about me in the slightest, but only wants to get clean.

I don't get a chance to change my mind. The old demoness unmercifully stabs her finger into Lora's stomach. "You heard the man! He doesn't want your grimy hands near him! Get back to the pits!"

Lora lowers her head again and beats a hasty retreat. I feel a little guilty as I glance at the empty pool room. I expected there to be others bathing here, but the place looks like it's been untouched for years.

"Why isn't anyone else here?"

The old woman snickers as she hefts her frame forward on a staff I didn't notice from before. "This ain't where the riff-raff are cleaned. We got hoses for that, boy. This place is reserved for important guests only. 'sides, ain't like the girls are gonna say anything. Hehe, you know what I mean."

I shoot a quick look of confusion at her. "I don't actually. I'm... new here."

"Oh." She looks disappointed. "Yama cut out their tongues and their vocal cords when they were taken. He and I both hate yapping serfs."

I can't even be horrified. I should be, but it almost seems expected at this point. Maybe demons really are monsters.

The old woman smiles at me far too sweetly. "Oh yes, you're such a polite young boy. It's been ages since I saw a male human, I forgot how charming they were. I am Hellga, third born of the Deuterich demon family. We are quite respected among others of our kind, you know."

Her name sounds about as disgusting as she looks. "I'm Jason, but you know that already. Listen, do you mind if I have some privacy?"

She shrugs. "I was hoping for a show, but suit yourself, boy. Make it snappy, we've already wasted enough of Lord Yama's time."

Hellga stomps away ungracefully, and once again I find myself wondering what is going on at this demon slave farm, even as I strip my clothes off and slosh into the remarkably warm water. It's already heated to the perfect temperature.

I shouldn't have turned Lora away. I'd like to have seen what she looked like once she was cleaned up...

* * *

I breathe a sigh of relief, finally realizing how much warmer I feel after that bath. While I was in there, Hellga had somehow sneaked in and swapped my nasty clothes out for a fresh pin-stripe suit. She guessed my measurements perfectly, though it feels odd to be wearing a suit in a place like this.

This suit is Japanese inspired, with eight buttons on the front grouped together in four clusters of two, and naturally, it comes in all-black. Yama's staff seem obsessed with that color.

I stand before a large oaken door now, circular in design. Without hesitation, I push it open and stroll into the room, surprised to see three demons here. Yama, two other red-skinned demons, and Blaarjiim's orb all greet me. There's also a lavish meal on the table, though the bulk of it is in front of the only open seat at the front of the table where I will presumably sit.

One of the newcomers, a male wearing a suit even blacker than mine, with eyes the color of rubies, glares at me as I walk forward. "So this is the human, then?"

Yama's small figure seems to be boosted up by a chair that's a bit taller than the others. I'd laugh if I thought it wouldn't make all these demons rip out my throat.

Though... I do wonder if I should really be scared of them.

"Yes. Jason Hiro. I'm sure you're all familiar with the name." Yama's voice is bland, even as his orb-like eyes flick down to the chair I'm to sit at. I calmly walk over and take my seat, being careful not to show any signs of fear in front of these demons. I don't know what's going on right now, but somehow everything continues to feel... familiar.

"How could we not be? He's-" The black-suited demon starts to speak but Yama cuts him off.

"Beelzebub. I'm the one who will do the talking."

The demon, apparently named Beelzebub, licks his lips and smooths his suit down with a practiced movement indicative of years worth of practice. "Of course. My apologies."

I take a moment to evaluate the other demon at the table quickly. He's a big behemoth of a demon, covered in battle scars, with a big flail inexplicably wrapped around his body, yet I feel as if I've seen him before.

The big one growls and picks at his teeth with a pinky. "The assembling of the three emperors, eh? When was the last time we bothered with this?"

"Don't be *thick*, Bael. If Yama wants us to gather, it's obviously for a significant reason." Beelzebub seems to mock the big demon, but he isn't having any of it.

"Are you mocking me, third?"

"No, no, of course not." Beelzebub retreats quickly, and his face flinches as if he had dodged an unseen blow.

While the two new demons have their verbal battle, I reach forward and yank a cookie off a plate before me. It's a plain thing, bland and brown with no special attention given to it, but I'd rather put something in my mouth than nothing. I'm starving. I take a tentative bite and am pleasantly surprised. It tastes like a simple sugar cookie, but it almost seems to be made with the care and devotion of someone who would ache to eat such a delicacy.

I chew it thoughtfully and Yama turns his attention back to me. "Now that the first and third are done squabbling. Let's get to it. Jason, we require your help."

I polish off the cookie and make them wait for a few seconds as I swallow. "Mmm. Is that so? I'd never have guessed."

"This is no time for jesting, Jason. Demonkind have barely been holding on what little territory we can, but there are only so many millennia of losses before we have to prepare ourselves for extinction."

I flick a glance at the door behind me. "You seem to be doing fine with the... slaves."

Yama tosses his hand up lightly. "We only use the chattel because we must. There are simply not enough imps to use as proper servants. You don't seem to grasp how efficiently my people are being exterminated."

He's right. I don't know. Don't really care, either. "These sound like excuses, Yama. I don't see why I'm so important." I dig my spoon into an odd looking brown mush, noting that despite its disgusting looks, it smells pleasant. "Wait, did you say millennia? How long was I inside that cryopod?"

All three demons glance at each other uneasily. "Millions of years." Blaarjiim is the one who answers my question. "Does this surprise you?"

"No... I guess it doesn't..." I murmur softly to myself as I stuff the salty brown mush into my mouth. It tastes a bit like meatloaf, perhaps?

It doesn't surprise me. Nothing does. This all feels wrong, so wrong. This isn't the way things are supposed to be. These demons aren't even the ones I should be talking to, I think.

It's there... on the tip of my tongue. I can't really put it into words, but I'm here for a purpose. What is that purpose, though?

"How did I kill Gressil?" I ask the question nonchalantly, but all three demons flinch and quickly try to hide flashes of anger. It seems Gressil was rather important to them.

"Wordsmithing. The power to make any idea come to reality with a single word. The word has to reflect what you wish to make happen, and there are a few limits to what you can do, but otherwise..." Yama's voice trails off.

"So when I said 'Die', I killed Gressil. That seems... simple." I smile slightly as I look over at Beelzebub. "What if I told you to die, eh, Beelz?"

His eyes narrow to slits. "Don't ever refer to me in such a manner, human. I won't die so easily to a mere word. Gressil was a fool and he ignored the safeguards. He got what was coming to him."

"The safeguards?"

Beelzebub quickly looks away. "Never mind. You wouldn't understand."

I quietly take a sip from a glass of red wine in front of me. "I suppose not. But if you would all stop beating around the bush, that could change."

The demons are hesitating. There's something they aren't telling me, as if they're afraid of what I'll say. Maybe they're afraid for a reason. Maybe they should be.

It's not just because I'm human. The demons need my power, the power of wordsmithing... but it also seems quite deadly. I'm a double edged sword.

Yama surprises me by pulling a black folder out of nowhere and sliding it across the table towards me. "These records should be sufficient."

I quickly grasp hold of it and lift it to my face. *Historical battles*. The white lettering on the front is faded and worn down, but it's in unmistakable English.

The entire room suddenly shakes as a thunderous *boom* sounds off, seemingly miles away. None of the three demons seem concerned in the slightest, but Yama notices my startled expression. "It's nothing. Human bombing runs. They won't find this place."

Indeed, another servant girl is on the other side of the dining room, scrubbing the floor, and she doesn't pay it any attention at all.

I turn my eyes back to the folder in front of me. This will finally answer the questions that have been plaguing me since I woke up.

I pull back the folder's first page and begin to read.

Part 388b:

It's not that what I'm reading is too horrifying to comprehend, I simply just don't know how to react to the words on the page. Accounts of humans capturing demons, butchering them in brutal, vile ways, and even performing barbaric chimeric surgeries before releasing demons back into the demon's realm to traumatize them... the journal of history is filled with dozens, if not hundreds of gruesome reports about humans treatment of the demons.

Yama watches me carefully as I flip through the pages of the dossier, finally speaking up once I have quickly scanned many of the grainy pictures. "You're not the only one who can use Wordsmithing."

I wait for him to continue, but he doesn't. I slowly set the faded folder down and slide it slightly away from me. I can't be bothered to eat any of the food anymore... I've simply lost my appetite. "Alright. So if I'm not the only Wordsmith out there, then that means...?"

Beelzebub harumphs and coughs audibly into his clenched fist. "The humans have an army of enhanced super soldiers. They're unstoppable in combat. We don't know who the first wordsmith is exactly, but we suspect he or she has given the power to many others. Wordsmithing has many practical applications, and is a special means of going beyond the laws of physics, as you might know them."

My hands somehow end up folded in my lap, though I don't know when I took my hands off the folder. Frankly, I'm just glad not to be looking at it anymore. "So why do I have this power, then? What makes me so important to you? Why not just take the power for yourself?"

Blaarjiim enters my mind. "It doesn't work like that. We're not sure how the original human did it, but he created an army of wordsmiths using his ability, and he's been using it to hunt us down and exterminate us. If demons could simply take the ability, we'd have done so by now." Blaarjiim gestures at Bael. "The first emperor, for example, is powerful enough that he might be able to capture a wordsmith by himself. As for you... well..."

Yama cuts him off. "You were part of a reserve unit. Apparently, the monster that terrorized our kind placed several humans he imbued with the power inside of stasis pods as a secret auxiliary force. We managed to take you, but we had no idea how to activate the unlock feature for the pod."

"No idea? That is hard to believe. It's a matter of pressing buttons."

"Mmm. Demons are terrible when it comes to understanding human technology. Assume that we simply 'pressed buttons,' what might have happened? We could have drained the fluid

improperly and killed you. We might have shut down the power wrong. If we had a human who was willing to help us, we probably could have taken you out but... such a human was never in play."

I lean back in my chair and scratch my head. This whole thing sounds very fishy. It's as if they planned their story all out in a way that would make some logical sense to me, but... there are holes in the plot. "I wasn't part of an auxiliary unit. I entered the cryopod willingly. I remember doing it because I was... well... I was depressed. I uh..." My voice falters for a moment as I feel a sudden rush of emotion. Yeah, that's right... I put myself in the cryopod because I didn't want to live anymore. I thought by donating my body to science I could perhaps improve the world around me.

Huh? What a joke. That's not me at all. I wouldn't do something so pathetic. Why did I really put myself in the cryopod?

The demons at the table evaluate me carefully, and it's at this moment that I realize... they're lying to me. They're lying about something big. I definitely wasn't part of some secret fighting force. Maybe my memories were altered or something, but that's unlikely as hell.

Why are these demons lying? What do they have to gain? Everything, now that I think about it. If I possess some crazy power that allows me to manipulate the universe with a single word, then I'm a living nuclear bomb. The demons aren't lying about being crushed by humanity; I can tell that much already. But as things are going now, the demons are probably going to ask me to give them my power, or copy it over or something.

As if. I don't trust anyone sitting at this table. They're using me.

However, I can just play along. I'll learn how my abilities work, and give them small favors here and there. Maybe I'll end up running the place in due time.

"A question, Yama. Why didn't you just capture a human scientist or two? If getting me out of the cryopod was your best hope, I'd expect you to have put a little more effort into the task. I mean, you have human slaves running around all over the place here."

Yama shakes his head slowly. "Your kind is crafty and aided by many brilliant minds. Their technology far outstrips our magical powers. Besides, these slaves are several generations past. They hardly bear any resemblance to the humans that exist outside of the labyrinth. All human scientists have small bombs planted in their brains just in case a demon were to capture them."

For once, Yama says something that surprises me. "Bombs in their heads? That's ridiculous. Why would they go along with such a thing?"

Blaarjiim interjects. "The reason, Jason Hiro, is that they must. Humans are led by a few undying never-aging immortals... plus the leaders of our worst enemies... the angels, as well as the Volgrim."

I involuntarily take a deep breath and exhale through my nose. "Angels. Volgrim. What the fuck is going on, even? I can guess what angels are, but Volgrim?"

"They are... ah... aliens." Beelzebub looks slightly flustered as he says this. "You likely come from a time before their arrival, but indeed aliens exist. They are extremely dangerous as well. Their technology might just exceed that of humanity's."

This is a lot to digest. I finally reach forward and poke at a strawberry with my finger, picking it up and ripping out the leafy stem before tossing the red fruit back in my mouth. Its softness and juicy texture are quite delicious, possibly the most normal thing I've tasted so far.

"Humans... Demons... Angels... Aliens... what's next? Necromancers, goblins, witches, giant fighting robots, and Godzilla?"

The demons at the table look back and forth at each other seriously for a moment or two before looking back to me. Yama speaks up. "Actually..."

"I don't even want to know." I cut him off quickly. "So let's get to it. You want me to use my powers to fight this war for you?"

" *With* us. You don't need to do everything by yourself." Yama beckons toward Beelzebub. "The third emperor will assist you in learning how your powers work."

Beelzebub's faint smile immediately crumples as he shoots an angry glare at Yama. "I beg your pardon? I don't recall signing on for such a task. I will not be a babysitter for a... *fleshbag*."

I first want to agree with him, but the insult makes me angry. If he hates humans so much, then I'll get a good chuckle out of ruining his day. "Beelzy, I think Yama has a good point. We could make a good team, you and me."

His crimson eyes light up with a most amusing fiery rage, and he rises slightly in his chair as if he wants to jump across the table and throttle me. "By the seven devils! I won't allow you to refer to me in such a disrespectful way!"

Yama, for once, shows a hint of a smile. "Now now, Third, you insulted him first. You deserved that."

Bael and Blaarjiim both nod along with Yama, and I quickly realize they don't particularly like the prissy, snooty jackwagon sitting across from me.

Beelzy slowly closes his eyes and breathes deeply before sitting back down. "Fine." He hisses the word out between his teeth.

I'm going to enjoy torturing this poor soul.

Yama stands up in his chair abruptly, his comically tiny self now towering over everyone at the table. "Well then, that should be the end of it. Third Emperor Beelzebub will assist you in using your powers, you will train to help us against the humans, and if you need anything, we are here to assist you."

Yes you are. I smile inwardly to myself and stifle an urge to lick my lips. I've hardly known demons for a day, and already I see how simple-minded they are. It's no wonder the genius of humanity has been able to pacify them to this extent. They couldn't even figure out how to unlock a cryopod.

I stand up too, popping my back and cricking my neck. "That will do then. Will I be able to get some sleep tonight?"

"Hmm. Right." Yama murmurs to himself, showing that he had once again forgotten about my human foibles. "Demons do not require sleep, so I forgot. My apologies. I will have the chattel clear out one of the- ah, no, those rooms are rather... grimy. I will have my assistant furnish something for you at once."

He nods at me and then shifts from the chair to the ground in the blink of an eye, moving as one with the shadows in the room. The room is hardly even illuminated by the candles all around the place, so the effect is rather... creepy.

"Just show me to an empty space. I'd like to try out this wordsmithing for myself."

Yama quickly turns from me to Beelzebub, shrugs, then looks back. "Do as you please, human."

He makes a quick motion with his hands, and a moment later Hellga limps into the room, looking disgusting as ever. "What be ye needin', Lord Yama?"

* * *

Several minutes of walking pass, as Hellga leads me back down those halls I had traversed earlier for my bath. This time, the path takes several rights and lefts, and it doesn't take long for me to give up trying to remember the way back.

"Just tell the serfs to lead ya back, it's all they're good for." Hellga grumbles under her breath when I inquire about the path, but she shoots an evil smile at me afterward. "Hehe, well, that ain't *all* they're good for. Human male like you will understand, I'm sure."

Naturally I grasp what she's talking about. The idea isn't repulsive to me, but it's simply not something I'm interested in. Taking someone who doesn't resist is not nearly as much fun as making a game of it or winning their affection.

Odd. I don't remember thinking like that before I entered the cryopod. I wonder why my personality feels so different now? Maybe the ice messed with my brain. Yeah, that's probably it.

Finally, we arrive at a rather large, plain looking doorway. It's a room not unlike that of the women's rooms all around me, but it's substantially bigger and less cramped, plus it's empty.

"I'll make sure Sheena gets you bedding, boy. This is last minute notice, after all."

"No, that's fine. I won't be needing their assistance." I smile politely at Hellga, even though the action repulses me. She is simply the most hideous looking thing I've ever seen, human or demon. In fact, every demon I've encountered so far has been quite good looking. Demons seem to pride themselves on their looks and status. I wonder why she is the exception?

I turn my back to her and think carefully about how I killed Gressil earlier today. Was it this morning? A few hours ago? Without the sun or a clock to be seen, time is hard to keep track of. The darkness seems to be stunting my biological clock too.

Let's see... it was a single word... something that conveys the meaning of what I want...

" **Bed.** "

I speak the word and feel a strange tingling in my body. An instant later, something vaguely resembling a bed appears in front of me instantly, startling me and making me take a step back. Even Hellga is surprised.

"Ye made it pop out of nowhere. Strange magic, that is."

I steal a glance at her face behind me. She's surprised by my magic trick, but what interests me is that despite what Yama spoke about a few minutes ago, she doesn't know what Wordsmithing is. If she's a well known and respected demoness, why doesn't she know about Wordsmithing? Wouldn't such devastating magic be well known to all demons?

Something doesn't add up here. Something is rotten in this labyrinth.

Hellga finally shakes her head and walks away, mumbling incoherently under her breath. Suits me fine, she's rather annoying to be around.

I glance back at the bed I've made. It's rather awful, misshapen, and nothing like what a bed should resemble. It slopes down at the angle closest to me, meaning the legs closest to me are shorter than the other two, and it's hardly more than a wooden frame. Mattress not included.

I try again. " **Bed.** " Instantly, another just like the one in front of me appears in midair and falls down abruptly with a loud *bang* that nearly makes me jump out of my skin.

Right, I wanted just to edit the existing one, not create another. This is a bit confusing. " **Delete.** "

I somehow feel as if I'm aiming my mind at the bed on top, and sure enough, it pops out of existence, disappearing into the nether. A thought crosses my mind. *Could this be a way I might kill someone? Do different words lead to different killing methods?*

I file that thought under *maybe* and resume work. This time, I don't summon another bed. Instead, I imagine the bed's legs raising up a few inches. "**Alter.**" Sure enough, the bed adjusts itself and now sits perfectly level.

So I can create things, remove them, and alter them. Those alone have... an astounding number of uses.

I quickly create a soft mattress, one that defies the normal limits of what comfort entails, and sit down gently on the bed. It's unbelievably soft, as if the moment I lay my head on my pillow, I'll be sleeping in an angel's arms.

I stare out the doorway. Now that things have quieted down a lot, I can hear the distant sounds of collective breathing, all around me. I passed many rooms on my way here, and it seemed to me that about half the girls sleep while the other half work, and they seem to rotate out at regular intervals.

"**Barrier.**" I create a soundproof invisible wall at my doorway, and instantly the sounds in the distance are cut off, and my room is weirdly silent. Still, I prefer hearing just my thoughts. Other people can be extremely annoying.

Time to play around a bit. "**Fire.**" I imagine a small flame appearing in midair before me, and sure enough, it appears. "**Sword. Shirt. Gun.**"

To my surprise, the gun appears in my hand, but it's even more misshapen than the bed initially was. Every piece of it is stuck together, and I quickly realize that I don't know what the inside of a gun looks like, only the exterior. It seems my abilities are limited by my imagination, but thus they only have that *singular* limit.

Well, I can't assume that much. There might be other walls I'll run into. Yama and the other demons were cryptic, to say the least. I have the feeling they're going to try and limit my growth.

I sit on the bed for a few minutes, just staring at the gun, before I finally shrug and lay down. I'll worry about it in the morning... or whenever I wake up. I guess 'morning' doesn't really exist in this place.

* * *

I need to piss.

My eyes jerk open, and I sit up in bed. I feel like I slept for a week, and my body is so rested that I don't even want to think about sleep anymore. In fact, sleep repulses me.

But more importantly, I need to piss. Really bad.

I quickly get off my bed and walk through my soundproof barrier, where the faint sounds all around me become audible once again. Where do they hide the bathrooms in these catacombs? Why are the hallways so meandering? Where is the dining room where I met the other demons?

Should I just wordsmith the piss out of myself? Tempting. I don't want to kill myself or something though accidentally, and I don't want to piss in a corner either. People live here, after all.

As I have these thoughts, I suddenly feel a presence beside me. Glancing to my left, I'm surprised to see a familiar figure standing a couple of feet away, and she isn't saying a single word.

Lora, as always, has her head downcast toward the ground, and it bothers me, as I was always taught by the orphanage adults to look people in the eye when I spoke. I guess the same isn't true for human cattle, as the demons seem to treat these girls.

"Lora. Is there a... um... bathroom here?"

I feel slightly embarrassed to ask, but she simply pushes past me and begins walking quickly away, so I shrug and follow along. She seems to understand speech perfectly well, so she isn't stupid... she simply can't talk.

Frankly, the thought disgusts me. I remember a quote I read once. *If you cut out a man's tongue, you have not proven him a liar, but only that you fear what he has to say.* It's not really the same thing since it seems the demons just don't like to hear humans talking, as if our very voices are an irritant. Still, it bothers me a lot.

Lora leads me down just a few short corridors before she finally stops in front of a very primitive looking toilet, really more of a latrine than what I'm used to. Unsurprisingly, it's designed for women, but it will have to do.

She continues to stand by the open doorway as I enter, and I realize she doesn't quite understand the concept of privacy. "Would you mind waiting around the corner?"

She walks away without acknowledging my words, and I relieve myself, sighing contentedly.

I wordsmith *water* to create a bubble of liquid in the air, wash my hands, and then make it disappear a moment later. Thinking back on it, if I'd used my head, I could have just created a toilet in my room. I'll have to remember that for the future.

I step out of the bathroom and spot Lora standing just around the corner a few dozen feet away, and wonder to myself several things all at once. Perhaps she can give me answers that others cannot, even if she can't speak.

I walk up to her and she stiffens noticeably as I draw closer. It unnerves me, as if she's scared of me. Probably a wise idea, if I'm being honest. I'm a killer, after all.

"Lora, do you understand me?"

I ask the question, and it takes several seconds for her to shift her feet. She doesn't give any indication she heard me, and instead keeps her head bowed to the ground.

"Just nod if you can, or shake your head if you cannot."

I hardly give her the instruction and she immediately nods her head. It's as if she won't do anything unless expressly allowed to do so.

"Would you be okay with looking me in the eye when I speak to you? I'm not like the demons."

Her hands quickly clasp together and she fidgets slightly. Just as I'm about to ask again, she slowly raises her head up to look at me.

I can't help but flinch. Her face is scarred, badly. It looks as if she was burned with several red-hot torture tools several times. Scar tissue is built up over other scar tissue. It looks inhumanly painful. The scars are years old by now, but whatever caused her the injuries to her face, it must have been horrible.

She must see the look of disgust in my eyes and quickly lowers her head again, and is now noticeably more uncomfortable, as she slightly pulls away from me.

I feel like an asshole.

"Sorry, I didn't realize... I mean, that is..." I quickly feel awkward, and then in the blink of an eye, an idea pops into my head. It's so obvious, but it's worth a try.

I reach over slowly, so as to not startle her, and carefully lift her chin up so she has to look at me again. The scars are old, and have been a part of her face for years now... but I can change that.

" **Heal. Repair.** " I speak two words, one after the other, and marvel to myself as the skin on her face softens and reforms, the valleys and lumps of mottled skin across her face smooth out and a transformation occurs. In seconds, she goes from a deformed young woman to something much more beautiful.

Then I do something else. " **Regenerate.** "

This time, a look of absolute shock passes over her face as she stumbles away from me and falls to the ground, grasping her throat and coughing weakly. I take a few steps forwards and kneel down to her level, worrying that I did something wrong. A few seconds later her weak

coughs begin to sound more audible, as her vocal cords stitch back together, along with her tongue. She stares at me in confusion before quickly jamming a hand in her mouth to touch the weird organ that wasn't there before.

"Can you speak now?" I force a smile as I look at her, and once she pulls her hand out of her mouth, she gives a valiant effort.

"Wrghh nsh"

My forced smile turns a little genuine as I try not to laugh. It's quite a serious thing and probably fills her with joy to have her body fixed up, but the way she speaks is just funny. Though, I don't know how long she hasn't had a tongue. If it was since infancy or young childhood, she never had any ability to speak and would take years of practice to learn.

At the least, it might make her eat food more comfortably.

I smile and stand up, trying not to break my arm patting myself on the back. Only then does a thought occur to me.

What if giving her back a face and a tongue is a bad thing?

If Yama doesn't like that I did this, then he might cut out her tongue and scar her face all over again. She would suffer for the second time in her life, and it would be all because of me.

Well, honestly, I don't care, I suppose, but yet I also do. This feeling is confusing.

I should probably take responsibility for what I've done.

She stands up and stares at me with a strange look in her eyes, almost something like that of awe.

My smile vanishes as I look at her. "You're mine now. I gave you back your face and tongue. I will tell Yama not to lay a hand on you. From now on, you do as I say."

She nods along, and her expression of awe fades as she too begins to realize the true repercussions of my actions. Soon, her expression is that of unease and wariness.

The look on her face is perfect. In this place, no-one is your ally. Everyone is your enemy. You have to look out for yourself. Already, I've come to realize that.

"Take me to Yama. I need to speak with him."

Part 389b: Squire

Lora knows this inner sanctum well. Everyone here acts as if they have a built-in homing beacon to wherever their destination is. As we take lefts and rights, the hallways turn into a blur, every black tiled wall looking the same as the next one. What are the walls even made of? Why does Yama live in such a dark, desolate place?

The questions flash through my mind, and even as I think them, I quickly discard the idea of asking Lora. She can't answer me back verbally, and her communication skills are rudimentary at best. She can only respond with head shakes and nods.

As we walk down the halls, I spot a familiar fireplace a few hundred feet in the distance, a straight shot down a corridor. "Is that the main room?"

Lora nods silently, and her hair stiffly shifts on her head. After I chat with Yama, I'm going to have to get her cleaned up. I'd prefer she not be dirty if she's going to be following me around.

We quickly walk towards the fireplace, and as we do, I spot a strange looking oak door on my left. It's cracked open a few inches, and a strange blue glow is emanating from the crack. Lora walks right past it and ignores it entirely, but I slow down a little bit and slyly peek inside.

It's a room filled with various tools and implements of all sorts, including hammers, chisels, items that look to be used for construction. The whole room is perhaps twenty feet square in all directions, and I'm surprised to see that the blue glow comes from a single object. There's a giant crystal of some sort, perhaps made of ice or something similar. Inside the crystal is a human girl, perhaps twelve or thirteen years old, standing loosely with her shoulders slumped forwards. Her eyes are closed, and she looks to be sleeping or something.

She's a little cutie, with long black hair and wearing a skin-tight black jumpsuit. I don't know why, but I am slightly interested in what put the girl in that situation. Why is she inside this room with all these random tools?

I jump slightly when Lora violently grabs me and yanks me away from the doorway, pulling it shut quickly. When I look at her in confusion, she shakes her head vigorously and looks around in fear. We're not supposed to be here.

I'm irritated that she'd treat me like that, but impressed by her courage. She's extremely deferential to me and treats me almost like a god of some sort, yet she doesn't hesitate to pull me away from this room by force. Clearly, she's scared of whatever is in there, or whatever might happen to me if I have a look.

As she should.

I decide not to question her motives and simply walk away. Whoever the girl is in that room, Lora probably knows enough of the story to want me to leave it alone. It's certainly none of my business.

A minute later, I walk into the dining room and am slightly surprised to see that Bael and Yama are not there. Only Beelzebub is, along with the black orb. Beelzy is carefully filing his nails down with a metal implement, and he raises his head up when I walk in.

"You're back already? You were hardly asleep four hours."

Lora stays behind at the doorway entrance and stands outside behind the wall, unseen. If Beelzebub noticed her, he gives no indication of caring. I walk in and sit down, and at that moment a door on the other side of the room opens up, and several slaves enter with food of varying sorts, quickly set the food on the table before me, and leave.

I blink in surprise at the food. "How did the slaves know I was coming?"

Beelzebub shrugs. "I don't pry into the Second's hospitality. Yama is a strange demon."

"You said it, not me." My hands move without thinking, grabbing a fork and spearing something resembling a plum and another thing which might be a chicken wing. I halt just before poking the wing with my fork as a weird sense of revulsion fills me. Instead, I grab an apple from my left.

After munching on the apple and plum for a few moments, I shift in my seat slightly as I feel Beelzebub's gaze beating down on me. "Is there something you want, demon?"

"Perhaps not." He hisses curtly at me, and I then feel Blaarjiim's presence fill my mind once again as if he's just been stirred from a deep sleep.

"Beelzebub, like Yama, is especially disgusted by humans." Blaarjiim's body for a moment appears almost reptilian, but it passes quickly, and I'm not sure if it's just my mind playing tricks on me. He stretches and seems to lay on a cloud of nothing. "I, however, do not share the same opinion. I find humans fascinating."

I swallow the chunk of apple I just bit off. "Fascinating? We aren't all that interesting, really."

"A human *would* think that." Beelzy rolls his eyes and sets the nail file down. "Yama will be here shortly. He is meditating to speak with the ancient dark gods."

"Is he really, now." I slip a rhetorical question in and glance back at the doorway. I can tell Lora is still sitting out there. For some reason, it bugs me having her sit away from the table. "Lora, come here."

She hesitates for several moments before slowly walking around the door, making sure to always stare at the ground.

I pull a chair out to my right. "Have a seat."

Her head tilts up slightly, and her hands wring together for a moment as she internally questions whether she should or shouldn't do it.

I decide not to give her a choice. "That was an order, not a request."

Since I was decisive with my words, she quickly moves around the chair and eases onto it, though she's sitting halfway off of it, as if she's ready to bolt at any second.

Beelzebub glares at her and then back at me. "Are you mocking me? I refuse to sit at the table with... with..."

I finish his sentence for him. "Another human? You can handle it, champ. Unless you're too weak willed, or something. Eh, Beelzy?"

I don't know why, but calling him 'Beelzy' fills me with a particular glee. The way his eyes smolder like hot coals every time I say it, it reminds me of something from long ago, something I can't quite put my finger on.

Maybe it's because he's just too easy to mess with. He gnashes his teeth again and wrings his hands, even as he forces himself to stay put. "You are *lucky* that you are under the Second's protection right now. If you were not a guest in his house, I would-"

Blaarjiim cuts him off. "That's enough, Third. You are far too easily goaded. It will be your undoing someday."

"If it hasn't already." I murmur under my breath as I shove a pile of beans in my mouth.

"What was that?" Beelzebub tries to say something else, but at that moment, Yama walks in from a side door towards his side of the table, at the head. From the corner of my eye, I spot Lora's hands start to tremble, and her whole body shakes.

Good. A little fear will whip her into shape once we leave this place.

Yama coldly stares at the slave girl. "What is this about, Jason?"

"I'm going to work with demons, and I've taken a liking to this slave girl. I'll be taking her off your hands."

He barely even shrugs as he walks over and climbs up into his comically high chair. "A demon's allies must always have slaves. I will allow this. However, next time you will ask me in advance. Do I make myself clear, human?"

I nonchalantly nod back at him. "Sure thing. So what are we going to do today?"

Despite his allowance for Lora to be my slave, Yama stares at her for several seconds before turning his attention back to me. "Beelzebub is going to train your wordsmithing, as I said before. You will go with him into the labyrinth and learn a few key things regarding magic."

I glance over at Lora and push a plate of food towards her silently before turning back to Yama. "I experimented with wordsmithing before I went to sleep. I think I already have the gist of it."

Beelzebub snickers, but Yama's expression is stone-cold. "We don't really have time for you to experiment, I'm afraid. We didn't have time a million years ago, and we're on the precipice of extinction now. You need to be brought up to speed on wordsmithing all at once. The humans are preparing for one final all-out assault. They have yet to find the Demon Emperor lairs, but the labyrinth has little left for them to map out. They can traverse it far faster than it expands."

I raise an eyebrow. "It expands? What do you mean?"

Blaarjiim speaks. "The labyrinth was created by the original First Emperor, Satan. When he was slain in battle, he gave the key to demonkind's survival to his closest followers. This labyrinth draws on the energy of demonkind to expand itself outwards. The more demons, the more energy, the faster it can expand."

Yama nods. "Indeed. But demons are very few in number now. The expansion has come to nearly a complete standstill. It took millions of years, but humans began to eventually explore and map the labyrinth, destroying it in the process, until the expansion slowed enough that they were able to make real headway."

"Sounds dire." I look back at Lora and notice she hasn't eaten yet. Her hands are still shaking, and she refuses to touch the meal. "Stick the food in your mouth, or you aren't eating for a week."

She hesitates still, but quickly leans forwards and takes the plate into her lap, ducking down a bit in a futile effort to make sure nobody can see her eat.

I don't exactly enjoy being vicious, but there's no room for weakness in this place. If she can't grow a backbone, despite whatever her life has been like, she'll just be in my way.

I turn back to Yama. "You know, something's really bugging me. If demons are in such a bad spot, what makes you think I'm going to help you? Only an idiot bets on a limping horse. What's in this for me?"

Beelzebub's expression lightens up for a minute, and he widens his eyes in approval. "Well, that's a very demonlike statement to make."

Yama doesn't look quite so pleased. "I have many slaves to choose from. Money, power, it can all be yours."

"Money? Power? I have the ability to create anything I want with my mind. Better yet, humanity probably has more of that to actually offer me anyway. Your offer is far too cheap."

The little shadow creature leans back in his chair and crosses his smoky black arms. He is very displeased. "What do you want, then? You are correct. We have... little to give."

I suddenly realize I'm not sure what I want. I crawled out of a freezing cold cryopod less than a day ago and stumbled into a universe I don't recognize in the slightest. What should I ask for?

"I want to be the king of demons. That should suffice."

Yama and Beelzebub both exchange a look of disbelief. Blaarjiim is the one to speak, however. "I thought you didn't care about power."

"I didn't say *that*. This is different, anyway. If I'm going to liberate and free your people, then I will lead them afterward. It's that simple. A man does not work for free, he must get something worth the trouble he goes to."

Beelzebub chuckles to himself. "Slaves would think differently."

Lora shudders at his remark. She doesn't like being talked about, especially by demons. I get the impression that slaves here do everything they can to not draw attention from demons.

I shake my head at his reply. "I am not a slave."

"Of course not." Beelzebub pulls the file out again and goes back to scraping at his nails. It's like some sort of addiction for him, resembling a smoker's addiction to cigarettes. "Just making a point."

"Your point is made." Yama hisses quietly. "Fine, if you merely wish to lead the demons, that is... doable. Bael will not be pleased but desperate times call for desperate measures. Honestly, he should be grateful your demand is actually possible. Please, however, realize that if we are eliminated by the humans, you will have no subjects to rule over, so winning is a requirement for us to fulfill our end of the agreement."

"I can handle that." I smile at Yama pleasantly, all the while thinking to myself *I'm not actually sure I can, but better to look confident*.

The room goes silent for a moment, and the only sound that can be heard is Lora chewing something, though she freezes and becomes self-conscious when she realizes people are looking at her.

Beelzebub stands up abruptly and pushes his chair away. "Well, I suppose we had best get going. Unless you care to wait for the chattel to finish her meal?"

I don't even need to respond as she quickly shoves the plate back on the table and bows her head again.

"I guess that's that, then." I stand up and she does too, though she stands up so quickly she almost knocks her chair backward. I stifle a laugh, but none of the demons look amused.

"Take Blaarjiim along. His power will significantly accelerate the task at hand." Beelzebub snaps the words out as he walks around the table to my side. "I assume you're going to ask to bring this female along. I'll only allow it if she doesn't get in the way."

"She won't." I shoot a look at Lora. "Right?"

She nods quickly.

I grab the black orb from its holder on the table. "We'll be back later, Yama."

* * *

I feel a vacuum of air blast out from around myself, as well as Lora and Beelzebub when we arrive. His method of teleportation feels very different from Yama's, though not unwelcome.

I quickly look around to take my surroundings in. A dimly lit chasm surrounds us, extending for miles in every direction, with the walls being visible from far away. The ceiling is not there; instead, a light much darker than that of a sun radiates from the sky above. The light feels mystical, as if it shouldn't exist, but yet it does.

The ground is not the same dingy brown that I walked upon in the labyrinth. Moss is everywhere, soft and supple as though I could lie down on it and take a nap. Flowers that glow softly dot the landscape, and mountains of rubble spring up here and there.

It's almost like an atom bomb went off, thousands of years ago, and the labyrinth is trying to reclaim its history.

A trail of smoke catches my eye, and I notice that a large patch of the crater we're standing in is smoldering from a recent fire. The moss is charred black.

Then I begin to pick out individual details. Some of the rubble is different from the rest. Smooth metal stands out in a way that nothing else does. Words, written in a language I don't know how to read. A spaceship, if I didn't know any better, is sunk into the ground, having plowed front-first into the dirt. By the looks of it, nobody cared enough to attempt to salvage the wreckage.

And then I spot other things. Robots covered in moss, long since deactivated, they lie in heaps, torn into scattered pieces here and there. Some of them have artificial skin still plastered over their body, with the metal underneath exposed. The result is a creepy collection of soulless killing machines.

Lora looks unnerved and pushes up next to me, her body hovering half an inch from mine.

"This place is distinctive, among demonkind and humankind alike. This is where it all began." Beelzebub waves his hand in a semi-circle. "This is where humans launched their first major assault against my people. Afterward, they returned to place these poisonous plants everywhere, as if to spite the sanctity of the labyrinth. They did this to prove a point."

"That they're in control." I finish his thought for him. "Humans can be like that. Are these plants actually poisonous though?"

Blaarjiim smiles evilly in my mind. "In a manner of speaking. They will not harm one who touches them, but they ruin the place that the first Devil created for his kind to live in. Plants and greenery do not belong here. They are part of the human homeworld, and thus belong to the humans wherever they live."

"Oh. So they aren't poisonous then." I try not to roll my eyes but can't resist. These demons are seriously getting uppity about adding a little color to the place? Goddamn, they're gloomy. Maybe some sunlight would do them some good.

Beelzebub walks forward a few paces and turns to face me. "We don't know the full extent wordsmithing can achieve, but we know a bit about it. For example, you can give your body unique properties, such as the ability to teleport without wordsmithing, and capacity to lift objects with your mind. I'll let you figure out how that works."

I blink in surprise. That information is surprisingly helpful. After pausing for a moment to consider, I decide to try it out. "**Teleport.**"

Nothing happens. I stare in confusion before realizing that I didn't think of where I wanted to actually go. This time I aim my mind a few dozen feet away into a clearing. "**Teleport.**"

The words hardly leave my mouth, and I feel my surroundings shift. My energy trickles down slightly, and Blaarjiim stirs in my hand. "That was a familiar sensation. It has been a long time since I experienced such an instant form of teleportation."

"Isn't teleportation by nature instantaneous?"

He shakes his head in my mind's eye. "No. Demons have to perform a small incantation, and the method of travel varies from demon to demon, as well as the distance they can travel. Yama uses shadows, while Beelzebub does something more like creating a body at the location he

wishes to move to, transferring his inner self to that body, and erasing the old one. As I said, it varies."

"Hm. Nice to know." I think for a moment before trying something else. " **Teleportation.** "

Once again, nothing happens, but I feel my energy dip more noticeably, perhaps 3% of my total reserves. Then I aim my mind at a nearby rock sticking up from the mossy floor. An instant later, I appear on top of it. The travel feels fluid, as natural as if I've been doing it my whole life. It happens as casually as taking a step.

"Fascinating. You're already getting the hang of it." Beelzebub stares at me intently, as if looking for weaknesses. Perhaps he wishes to exploit them, or maybe he's looking out for my well-being and areas to improve. I won't hold my breath on the latter.

"As I said, I practiced a little bit already." I flex my fingers and curl them into a fist, flexing slowly. "I feel a sort of inner energy dip every time I use my power. What happens if I run out? Will I die?"

Blaarjiim doesn't hesitate. "No. You will be unable to use magic and may fall into a deep sleep, but otherwise, you will be fine. Of course, using up all your energy is only likely to happen in a life or death situation, so falling asleep is probably a death sentence. Try not to let yourself slip up in that case."

"Wonderful."

Blaarjiim nods. "Humans recover their energy when they sleep, so your reserves are functionally unlimited, but it is finite for spurts of time."

Hmm. My powers are really something. The ability to change the fabric of reality as I know it, give myself other powers, create and destroy... I'm... I'm a god, aren't I? If I am a god, then what of the others with wordsmithing? Are those people not even more godly than myself?

Perhaps aligning with the demons is foolish. My main goal should be to eliminate my competition, then subjugate the rest.

We will see.

Without putting effort into the act, I teleport back to Lora and she squeaks in fright. Apparently, she didn't expect that. "Calm down. If you're going to be here in the labyrinth, it would be idiotic of me to not give you any protection."

I speak a few words, back to back. " **Sword. Shield. Boots. Bracers. Armor. Helmet.** "

In seconds, a full set of plate mail armor appears and falls to the ground with a loud clang. I then create a set of undergarments for her to wear, since those disgusting leather strips will not protect her from the metal's chafing, and they look quite ugly at this point.

"Put the clothes and the armor on. They'll be heavy, but it'll help build up your strength. Once you've done that, I want you to swing this sword over at that wall until you're too tired to move."

She glances up at me and then back to Beelzebub, unsure of what to do, but then quickly starts to undo her shirt. I turn away out of politeness so she can have a bit of privacy, not that she seems to care.

Walking back over to Beelzebub, I smirk as he rolls his eyes. "You've really taken a fancy to that slave girl, eh, human?"

"Well, *Beelzy*, unlike you I can actually care about another of my kind without acting like it's the end of the world. Maybe you should stop being so heartless."

For once, he doesn't get mad at me for calling him that moniker. Instead, he turns slowly and gazes at the mossy ground all around us. "I did care about my kind, once. And then slowly but surely, the ones I cared about were stripped away. One by one, the humans took them."

My eyes lower, almost by their own volition. His lack of an annoyed reaction makes me regret poking fun at him. Demons are so... depressing.

A clank behind me makes me turn around. Lora is no longer wearing the tattered rags, and instead, is dressed in a loose-fitting long-sleeved white shirt and pants, and has already put the metallic boots on with surprising speed. She seems to be puzzling over the chest plate though, as if unsure of what to do with it.

I walk back over to her and take the armor from her. "Here, hold your arms straight up. I'll put it on for you."

She nods and does what I tell her to do, though it takes a couple tries for her to figure out which hole is for her head and which ones are for her arms. Finally, she manages to slip into it and breathes an audible sigh of relief. Reflexively, she raps the armor with her knuckles and then surprises me by smiling ever so slightly. She likes it. The armor is quite heavy, but I'm not taking it easy on her just because of her life so far. When life gives you lemons, you have to make lemonade.

Eventually, she puts all the rest of it on, and when she finally holds up the shield and her sword, she's breathing heavily. Already, she's feeling the weight of the armor. The shield is white on the front, with a red cross emblazoned on it. I don't remember imagining that specifically, but I suppose some Crusader imagery might have slipped into my mind somehow. The sword is a longsword, over two feet in length with a plain steel hilt, wrapped tightly with leather for easier gripping.

And Lora looks absolutely unintimidating. If I saw her charging at me in battle, I'd probably die of laughter before the sword had a chance to clumsily stab at me.

Still, I have to say the get-up does look rather... cute? Yes, kind of adorable in some ways.

Lora trudges off to go swing the sword at the wall as I instructed, and Beelzebub snickers audibly. I turn back to look at him. "What's so funny, demon?"

He laughs harder, this time having to cover his mouth to prevent a real uproar. "By the seven devils, that has to be the most pathetic bodyguard a king could ask for! She'd be better off jumping into the path of a sword to stop it from hitting you than trying to actually fight! Pahaha! Humans truly have no concept of futility!"

I smile curtly at him. "You're right. It's pointless for her to fight as she is now. But every man, every human that has killed a demon, started off as a child. Only trials, tribulation, and training could make a weak child into someone who could kill demons en-masse. I'd watch your mouth if I were you. That woman is more likely to be the final slayer of the demon race than you are to reclaim this labyrinth."

Beelzy's smile comes to a total halt, and he sputters in protest, but I continue. "Actually, I've noticed something fundamental about demons that makes them different from humans. Demons and humans both believe in the power of the individual, but humans alone understand that only by cooperating and pooling their resources can they become an invincible fighting force. Demons are solitary creatures who only rely on one another at the minimal level. Perhaps if you had worked together more, you might have stopped the humans from crushing you in the beginning."

I smile sweetly at him. "Perhaps you could have saved those friends of yours from being counted among the corpses in this labyrinth."

Beelzebub and I stare at each other for several long moments, as the sound of Lora smacking her sword against the wall rings off in the distance.

"I hope that outburst pleased you, human."

"It pleased me just fine, Beelzy."

Before he can say anything, there's a faint rumbling in the distance, as if a bomb went off. The walls in the chasm shake slightly and dust falls from the unseen tops of the walls above. A massive chunk of the wall comes falling down several miles away, smashing into the ground with a resounding crash.

Beelzebub licks his lips as he cocks his head. "Humans. Another bombing run, by the sound of it. And... they are drawing closer."

Blaarjiim smiles in my head. "Well then, seems you might be getting field testing soon, boy."

I frown. How could the humans know we were here? Coincidence? Or perhaps something else?

I glance over at the robotic corpses and the shell of a spaceship sunk into the earth. What if the humans left behind detection devices? That's what I would do, and it's not like the demons understand technology very well.

Beelzebub turns back to me. "You should speak 'disguise' and make yourself and that girl look like demons. The only thing humans hate more than demons are humans who turn traitor and work alongside my kind."

"Humans have fought alongside demons? I find that hard to believe."

Beelzebub shakes his head and smiles wryly as he jams his hands into his suit's pockets. "There have been a few. They paid the price for trying to avert the war. And others... gave up on their ideals."

His words feel like they have extra meaning to them, but I decide not to pry. "Whatever. I'll do it. **Disguise. Disguise.** "

I aim my mind at Lora and myself, wondering if this really is a good idea. Lora doesn't even seem to notice her skin turn red as she swings at the wall, and her back is turned to me so she doesn't see me either. In fact, she's quite absorbed in the whole training thing, and she's breathing hard, with sweat pouring down the back of her neck. She really gives it her all. Very admirable.

I teleport over to her. "Lora. Stop training for a moment." I quickly summon a bottle and fill it with ice water and hand it to her. "You're doing great so far. Take a quick breather and then keep at it. Drink water and let me know if you need anything."

She smiles at me, and for once it's a genuine feeling. She really is quite happy about how things are, despite how coldly I've been treating her.

Her red skin and demonic looking body doesn't contrast well with the crusader-style armor, making her look like some kind of imposter, but she won't be fighting if the humans show up, anyway. I'll keep her out of the way. She'll just slow me down as she is now.

But... in the future... hmm.

I walk back over to Beelzebub. " **Telekinesis. Telepathy.** "

I quickly use my new abilities, which I somehow know exactly how to use, and scan Beelzebub's brain. For some reason, the images I receive are very obscured and abstract, almost as if he's thinking in a different language than I am.

Beelzebub stiffens and glares at me. "Get out of my head, human. I'm not playing around any longer."

His eyes are far angrier than they ever were before, so I quickly retreat. This time I sense real bloodlust. "My apologies. I just wanted to test my telepathy to ensure it worked."

His right hand slowly pulls out of his pocket and he balls it up into a fist and shakes it at me. "Your slave is over there. I'd advise you use your abilities on a more appropriate test subject in the future. Am I *clear* enough?" He leans in closer and hisses at me, so I take a few defensive steps back.

"Yeah, sorry. My bad, alright?"

He glares violently for a few moments longer before pulling away and turning his back to me.

Out of curiosity, I decide to follow his advice and aim my mind over at Lora, now sitting down for her break and slowly drinking the water I gave her. I wonder what she thinks about?

A moment later, I get my answer.

Pain. Hatred. Inescapable fear. Never-ending torture.

Mama! No!

A little girl reaches out her hand as the red-skinned monster tears the older woman limb from limb, greedily devouring her entrails.

Quiet, filthy human! You're too young! Haven't even been bred yet! Learn your place!

A hand flies forward. The little girl falls backward as the hand smashes across her face. A tooth falls out and rolls along the ground and the child cries out in sadness.

But this is not Lora. I am looking through Lora's eyes. I stand silently with my head bowed and flinch every time the demon makes another loud slurping noise. After he's finished, the monster stands up and bellows at me.

Chattel! Clean this mess up, or you're next!

I quickly fall to the ground and scoop up the body parts that are left over, still oozing blood and other unthinkable things. I do not flinch, as I have done this a thousand times. I do not process it anymore. It's normal, it's just a part of life. In time, the little girl will grow used to it as I did when my mother was devoured.

And I will be devoured someday, too. There is no hope of leaving this place alive.

My mind escapes Lora's with a rush and I suddenly realize there is a cold sweat pouring down my back. What the fuck? That was unreal. I knew demons were probably bad, but this is...

I shoot a glance at Beelzebub, who is staring off into the distance, ignoring me. Has he done these vile things? Am I making the right decision?

Beelzebub whispers, so quietly I can barely hear him. "They're here."

I blink back tears, wondering in passing where they came from. The vision, perhaps? A moment later I discard the thoughts as I catch sight of several humans marching forward across the way, headed right towards us.

Instinctively, even though I don't really want to, my telepathy jumps over to them and scans their mind.

Target spotted. Two bogeys. No, three. Two individuals unknown. Third is potentially one of the demon emperors. Advise on course of action.

I stare silently at the humans for a few moments and take them in. They're wearing some sort of white full-body suit, a lightweight armor made of an unknown material, with a golden emblem of a winged bird of prey across the chest. They have helmets with a full visor across the face, something like a one-way mirror that they can see through but I can't.

"Prepare yourself, boy. This is your true test. The Golden Commandos are the most dangerous force we could have encountered." Blaarjiim helpfully reassures me in my mind. "The odds are a hundred to one that you'll die here."

"Don't ever tell me the odds."

Part 39ob:

The humans up ahead, or 'Golden Commandos', as Beelzebub calls them, chatter silently to each other inside their helmets. I wouldn't know what they were saying at all, if it weren't for my telepathy.

I quickly realize telepathy is a two-way street. I send a thought to Beelzebub. *Are you able to hear my words?*

He doesn't show any annoyance at my mental communication, since he only hates it when I read his mind. He pulls his hands from his pockets and makes a small motion, then I hear his own voice inside my head. *Yes. Using telepathy to prevent giving out our battle plans, then? Smart.*

It's obvious. The humans are speaking inside those helmets, but we can't hear them. This is just smoothing out the playing field.

Our mental communications are interrupted when a human steps forward, pushing past the scouts in the frontline. While wearing a tactical battle suit like the others, this one appears to be some sort of tactical unit, or a commander, given three stars on his shoulder pad.

His faceplate slides open a moment later and- oh, I was wrong. It's a woman. A blonde lady with a distinctive military aura about her. Her curly hair spills out of the helmet, and she glares at us. "I am Amy Gutierrez, Corporal of the 3rd Golden Commando Corps. With my authority as a military commander, I'm placing the three of you under arrest. Resist, and we will cut you down without mercy. Concede, and we will offer you a fair trial."

I start to speak, but Beelzebub cuts me off. "Hah! Fair trial! I've seen what your kind do to demons in your trials! I believe the term humans use is 'kangaroo court'! What reason do you have to arrest us? We're merely standing here!"

The woman bites her lip savagely before responding. "You're demons. That's all the reason I need."

"As I expected from a filthy human. Have you no shame? Have you no compassion? Demons are no threat to you, yet you continue to hound us! You-"

She interrupts him harshly. "Quiet down, monster! I don't want to hear your pathetic wailing! Either give up or die. I am giving you the mercy of choosing your fate."

Beelzebub sends a mental message to me. *You have telekinesis now, correct? I recommend you start figuring out how to use it.*

Then he speaks again. "The only choice you're giving me is a choice between a swift or a slow death. Luckily, the reign of humanity is soon to come to an end. The rise of the demons is about to begin. And you, nasty female, will be the first to bear witness to it."

She raises an eyebrow questioningly before her helmet snaps shut, a few strands of her hair getting caught in the process, though she ignores them. I flinch as I hear her thoughts echo her words inside the helmet. *Open fire!*

As if on cue, I grab Beelzebub's arm, teleport over to Lora, grab her shoulder with my other hand, and teleport us to a corner of the room behind some debris. This happens in the span of just a few seconds, right as a hail of energy blasts shoot for a few moments at where we were just standing, before stopping, as if the humans are suddenly confused about where we vanished to.

How do I take them out?

I send the question over to Beelzebub, and he smiles at me, a most cunning expression. I don't like the look it gives him. *You're the one who is supposed to prove himself. You figure it out. I will warn you however that those energy beams will shred even myself to pieces, and you will fare even worse than I. Take care not to be struck down. The humans are light on mercy, and quick to sever limbs.*

I feel a shift in the humans' minds as a large hovering vehicle pulls out of the far wall's entryway and into the central mossy area.

Beelzebub, for once, offers help out of the blue. *That is a specialized field scanner. Humans use them to hunt shadow-walkers and beings similar to Yama, but it will be quite adept at rooting out our position. You haven't much time before it sweeps the area.*

Great. I love being rushed. I flick a glance over to where the red-suited commander woman was, but she isn't there anymore. I don't see her. There's still the spaceship crashed in the center of this chasm, so anyone could be on the opposite side and I wouldn't be able to see them. How troublesome. The moss blends in after a while, making distance gauging difficult past a certain point. If only I could sneak over there with the humans seeing me.

Yeah... without them seeing me... maybe if I could turn invisible...

Oh. That's a good idea. I speak the word out loud, but we're far enough away from the group from earlier that they haven't a chance of hearing me. " **Invisibility.** "

Like something out of a horror film, I smile to myself as my hands suddenly vanish, along with the rest of myself. Beelzebub's smile grows even wider. *That human vehicle will still be able to detect you with its magic scanners, but I applaud the ingenuity. What now?*

Blaarjiim pipes up for once, offering his own thoughts into my mind. "You'd best be careful. Those human suits are deceptively sturdy. They're made of a material far harder than diamonds, so whatever plan you have to kill them, brute force won't do it."

I squeeze his orb a little tighter in my grip. *Good to know. I need to get myself one of those suits then. I'm not very strong as of now.*

To say the least. I have no protection. Lora's armor is probably only perfunctorily better than wearing no armor at all, especially against whatever those blasters are shooting.

I decide to wing it a little bit, and teleport over to the very top of the spaceship.

When I arrive there, I'm quite surprised by the size of the group below me. Several hundred of the humans are wearing those thin suits, and they are all on edge, looking all around, and even up in the air at me. I flinch for a second, before realizing they can't see me.

Wait, can they? I only made myself invisible. Even before I went in the cryopod and everything became like Star Trek with technology, heat scanners were a thing. What about sonar? Am I detectable with other means? Ultraviolet?

An idea springs to mind. I won't know if it works until it's too late but better safe than sorry. Quietly, I whisper under my breath. " **Invincible.** "

I suddenly feel dull and have to blink my eyes as a strange feeling of disorientation passes over me. Swooning for a moment, I use my free hand to stead myself, only to realize when I place it on the ship underneath me, I can't feel anything. My sense of touch is gone. Even my eyes feel weird, and my mouth.

As I'm reeling, I yank my eyes open forcefully when I spot several of the commandos grouping up and looking in the direction of the rubble I hid Beelzebub and Lora behind. They've been found. Not much time left.

There are several hundred commandos. I could kill them with wordsmithing, but I don't think I can do it faster than one at a time, and speaking out loud has a chance to give my position away early. I need something faster.

Blaarjiim speaks into my mind as if reading my thoughts. "Yes, good. You're onto something now. Keep thinking. Your girlfriend hasn't got much time now."

Shut the fuck up. If she dies, it's because she was too weak. I'll do what I can, but I'm not a babysitter.

No, instead I need to think. I can apply effects to myself and make them permanent, or remove them. I just need to think in terms of efficiency.

The humans start to move quickly towards Beelzebub and Lora, making chopping motions with their hands as they fan out to surround.

What to do... what to do...Well, for starters, I can at least hassle them.

Expending a small amount of energy, I send out all of my telekinesis at once, yanking every single commando at once backward. In fact, I accidentally use way more power than intended, and fling them backward at comical speeds, as if they were hit by a freight train going 300 miles an hour.

Several of them smash into the spaceship underneath me, other go flying all the way back into the far walls. Their thoughts, however, remain remarkably calm.

Telekinetic surge detected. We've located the origin point.

All at once, several heads swivel up to the spot where I'm standing in unison.

The bogey is using a rudimentary cloaking field. Move to intercept.

Shit. As I thought. They can see me. I'll test whether they can actually hurt me if it comes down to it, but I'm still not entirely confident in my abilities yet.

I teleport away a moment later but arrive very close to another human. The commando's head immediately spins to look at me, and I shove him away with a telekinetic blast, sending him tumbling end over end. Based on the reactions of the commandos from before, it seems they can see me, now that they know I'm invisible.

"Seems the game is over, Jason. That is, unless you can think of something else."

Blaarjiim almost seems to be taunting me. Too bad for him, I'm not even close to out of options. If humans do know about Wordsmithing, I'll be at a disadvantage if they hear me using it. Right now I might have the element of surprise on my side, but I should make sure they can't hear me wordsmithing...

A helmet and a suit like theirs would do, but I don't want to be impaired just yet with a foreign armor, especially if it slows me down even slightly. I have a better idea.

" Muffle. "

I aim the word at myself and then speak again, and this time I can't even hear myself speak. However, I can tell my words are still being spoken. My wordsmithing will continue to work.

I send a telepathic message to Blaarjiim. *Do these humans have spiritual energy, like me?*

He nods an affirmation. "They do. However, due to your... situation... your spiritual levels are an ocean compared to their puddles. Why? What are you thinking?"

Two pronged attack. I gain, and they lose. Let's test it out.

I speak a word, and it vanishes silently into the ether. " **Draining.** "

Just in the nick of time too. The commando I sent flying brought reinforcements, and they're surrounding me. Teleporting away would be easy, but this isn't about escape. This is about winning. These fuckers are durable as sin, but they still have fleshy bodies inside those suits...

The group levels their weapons at my invisible form, right as I send out a wave of energy. This time, I target their bodies, and my draining effect leaps into them, sucking the energy right from their bodies and siphoning it back to me. I feel a piddling amount of energy fill me, but the effect on the commandos is instant. They slump backward and fall to the ground, comatose. It seems I drained them to a ridiculous point, where their brains ceased functioning properly and they entered a deep sleep.

Even as I have that thought, a smaller group behind the one I just took down steps backward in alarm. I hear their thoughts speak up again. *S-Class threat. Confirmed abilities are teleportation, invisibility, telekinesis, and some sort of psychic attack. Permission to enable Containment Protocol?*

A moment later, an unheard reply comes through and the group quickly nods in unison.

What the fuck is a containment protocol?

Even as I ask the question, I feel a weird vibration in the air as the edges of their suits glow and change to a yellow color.

"You'd better leave. Now." Blaarjiim's voice suddenly raises in alarm. "They're getting serious now. They just surrounded their bodies with anti-energy."

Even as I feel my telepathic link to the commandos sever, I quickly grasp what he means. I try to send another wave of draining at them, but the effort is immediately futile. It bounces off of an unseen barrier, vanishing into the nether.

Things are looking better every minute! And here I was worried I wouldn't get a fun fight.

I teleport several miles away to the other distant side of the chasm and arrive back where Beelzebub and Lora are sitting. Humans are already here and about to surround them.

Beelzebub, would you be so kind as to take my slave away from here? I'd like a bit of privacy.

He immediately whips his head around, looking for me, but realizes it's futile as I'm invisible. "I have no such obligation to protect chattel."

Do it or I'll have Yama spank you when we get back.

He doesn't get mad but instead smiles another of his signature creepy grins. "You'll pay for that remark. Fine, I'll humor you. Don't disappoint me, now."

Without waiting for a reply, he flips up and over my invisible form in one smooth motion, displaying a grace I should have expected from him, and lands right beside Lora. She instantly cowers when she realizes he's there.

"Oh, bugger off. You're under Jason's protection, wench. I'm here to save your filthy life." He rolls his eyes dramatically before making a motion with his hands. A moment later, both of them vanish.

And not a moment too soon, as I spot a human walking around the other side of the rubble in front of me. He quickly aims his gun and fires, but I teleport to the side and hit him with a telekinetic blast. The blast fizzles though, doing nothing to him.

Damn. Here I thought it would still send him flying since it was indirect. Well, *this* will, in any case. I instead aim my mind at a ten-foot boulder to my side and lift it out of the ground, sending it at him with a rush. It smashes into him from behind, and the poor soul is crushed instantly.

Yeah, jackass. Negate *that*.

And right after I think that thought, the boulder shifts again, and the commando crawls out from it, unhurt. Do those suits give them super strength as well? Jesus, what am I up against?

I teleport to the center of the mossy chasm and speak another word. " **Flight.** "

This time, I feel my energy begin to drop at a steady pace. Simply having this spell active drains my energy. Ignoring that thought, I fly up into the air- and immediately my energy starts to drop at an alarming rate. This ability drains a ridiculous amount of power!

Quickly I scan the area below me. Hundreds of humans are already tracking my position, invisibility be damned, and only a few dozen were rendered comatose. How do I kill them? I may have already squandered a ridiculous number of options now that they've activated their abilities... but surely those suits have some weakness.

A thought rapidly comes to mind. What happens when an unstoppable force meets an immovable object? Perhaps I shouldn't be focusing on weakening *them*, but enhancing *myself*.

I deactivate my flying ability and teleport again to another location in the arena, and by now I can tell the commandos are getting annoyed with my constant teleporting. This place is far too big for them to effectively blanket the area too, so there's always empty spots for me to go to.

The first thing to do is retake my invisibility. I don't know how they're seeing me, but body heat is as likely a source as any. " **Reptile. Phasing.** "

Now my body will become reptilian, allowing my blood to cool down. For some reason, this idea comes to my mind naturally, as if I've thought of it before. I shake my head quickly and scatter those thoughts away. Everyone experiences déjà vu.

That rock managed to knock out the commando before. Or at least it knocked him down. What does this mean? It means they aren't invincible. They can take a lot of damage, and maybe I can't kill them now, but I can immobilize them.

I aim my mind at a commando several hundred feet away. He's looking around for me, so maybe my reptilian ploy worked. "**Rock.**"

A massive rock appears in the air above him and falls down, crushing him into the ground instantly. However, a few moments later, I notice the rock starting to shift slightly. As I thought the suits must be enhancing the wearer's strengths too.

"**Heavy. Heavy. Heavy. Heavy.**" I speak the words rapidly, aiming my mind at the rock. Sure enough, the rock finally stops moving and the commando is trapped underneath. I'm not sure if he's been crushed to death, or is just immobilized, but this is working fine for what I need.

Still, making hundreds of big boulders is impractical. I need another solution.

Those suits. What powers them? No way these high-tech suits aren't running off electricity or something, right? Maybe they use some crazy plutonium stuff, but I can't know that without getting to see how they work. My best guess is that if they're really high-tech, something's gotta give when it comes to electronics. And that gives me another idea.

"**Lightning.**"

I aim my mind at my own body, imagining the word as an abstract concept. *The ability to fling bolts of lightning.*

I'd be shocked if this works. Even if it doesn't, it's worth a shot.

"**Agility. Agility.**"

My mind is racing with ideas now. There are so many ways I can tackle this situation.

I run towards the boulder and jump at it, my hand racing forwards to propel me over the rock like an Olympic gymnast, making me triple front flip and land on my feet as if I'd done it a million times before. I haven't, though. I've always considered myself more of a slacker, and definitely not athletic. This is so badass.

Commandos are already moving to my position, though they don't seem to see me once again. I aim my hand at them and imagine an electrical sensation pulsing through my body. A moment later, a colossal blast of energy flies from my body and smashes into one of the

commandos nearest to me. Unlike the telekinesis earlier, this attack hits, knocking the commando backward several feet. When he lands, he doesn't move for several seconds as pulses of electricity dance over his suit. Finally, some sort of internal dampener activates and a quick *bzzt* sounds off, allowing him to stand up once again.

Troublesome. I thought that would work.

I need more information. These commandos are way beyond what I was prepared for... but they can be beaten. I just need to learn their weaknesses.

I teleport away, leaving the humans to their own business. Using my telepathy, I scan the area around me until I locate a familiar mental feeling, one that can only belong to Lora. I arrive next to her and breathe a sigh of relief as I speak another word. "**Normalize.**"

The muffled feeling vanishes, as does the invisibility, and Lora squeaks when I appear right next to her out of nowhere. Only when she stares at me for several seconds do I realize I might have forgotten something. I reach up to scratch my head and spot my hand, now covered in scales. Ah, the reptilian thing. Forgot to dispel that too.

We're in a small room now, at least a mile from the chasm itself. Beelzebub knows how to pick a safe spot, though the room is rather barebones, just made of earthen walls covered in dirt and grime and no furniture or decorations to speak of. It's like the worst prison I could have thought of if I was designing one.

I take care of that, and Beelzebub chuckles to himself. "Couldn't do it, could you? Golden Commandos are unstoppable once they activate those anti-energy fields of theirs."

"Unstoppable? Then why don't they just open with those?"

Beelzebub scratches his chin. "I wonder that myself, sometimes. Maybe it's for sport. They know demons are no threat anymore, so they only use the suits true power for dangerous situations. Maybe there's a downside. All that matters is... once they activate those anti-energy fields... even I can't hurt them."

"Hm." I grunt a little bit and glance at Lora. She seems a little flustered, but otherwise unaffected by the whole situation. Then again, she wasn't the one fighting. I'll have to change that, given time. "Let's get out of here. I need some solitary training. This has taught me... a lot."

Blaarjiim is somber about the whole thing. "Nothing like live combat to make you realize what you're up against."

"Yeah. I saw how the humans treated you as a monster. Now I see that it goes both ways."

Beelzebub nods sagely. "We are merely defending ourselves from unwanted invaders. Soon you will come to see it from our point of view."

Despite my words, I still feel uneasy. There was the mental vision I saw when I looked into Lora's mind, plus what I've seen of demons myself. Maybe humans have the right idea, exterminating the demons. Then again, who started this war first? It's difficult to distinguish the true villain when both sides are hypocritical. One cannot simply hold someone else to a higher standard while ignoring that standard themselves.

But really, do I care? If the demons are evil, or the humans, I should be looking out for myself, either way. The demons just want to use me, and I'm sure the humans would love to get their hands on me as well.

Fuck both of them, honestly.

"Let's get out of here, Beelzy."

He grimaces. "I still owe you for that remark you made earlier. Truly, you test my patience."

Hehe. Beelzy's all bark and no bite. The demons must have been desperate to make this guy a demon emperor.

I wonder how highly ranked a demon emperor is, anyway? Sounds similar to a demon king. I'll have to ask when I get back.

Beelzebub makes a motion with his hands, and a moment later I feel a familiar sensation as my mind and body are sucked from this place to a new destination.

Part 391b: Limit Breaker

Lice. Lora has lice. The most disgusting thing that I could imagine, and it infests her head. I found this out only a few minutes ago when one of the little vermin was crawling on my shirt. Upon a quick inspection, I discovered the culprit was the woman walking beside me, helping me map out the hallways in Yama's home.

Thanks to my newfound understanding of how this place is laid out, I quickly walk Lora along until we arrive at the bath-house I've used twice since I appeared in the Labyrinth a couple of days ago. Hellga just happens to walk by as we show up, and for once, I'm delighted to see her disgusting face.

"Hello, human. What can I get ya?"

Her greeting is about as pleasant as I expected. "Lora has head lice. That won't do. I want you to scrub her as clean as possible and make sure they're gone."

Hellga stares at me for several long seconds, her mouth hanging half open. "Human, there are many things this old broad is willing to do... that is not one of them. Do it yourself."

"No, you *will* do it. Otherwise, I'll have a little chat with Yama, see what he has to say."

The old demoness is incredulous, but after a few seconds, she groans madly and grabs Lora by the wrist, pulling her away from me. "Only because you asked so politely."

"Gracias."

I watch as the two of them enter, before creating a seat and plunking down outside the bath-house.

Things have been quiet for the last two days. After my encounter with the Golden Commandos, I've been experimenting a bit with my abilities. As it turns out, Invulnerability and Invincibility are effectively the same, though they both have the downside of making me lose my sense of touch. I can't regain it either, not even by wordsmithing "Touch" or anything similar.

Wordsmithing isn't omnipotent, as it costs energy. I was able to drain a decent cluster of commandos of their energy, but the amount was piddling at best. Yama tells me that human energy is hardly existent, compared to demons and angels.

Angels... so even they exist? Yama and the other demons are being deliberately tight-lipped about them. How many are there? What abilities do they have? How strong are they compared to demons? Are demons and angels mortal enemies, like in the Bible and other works of myth?

What if I could drain an angel of its energy? How much could I gain? Hell, forget Angels for a second... what about a demon? They're everywhere around me. Would anyone miss Hellga if she were to go missing? She's probably not very strong, though. Yama would probably give me a lot, as well as Beelzebub and Bael.

But I can't afford to take on the demons. Assuming I did manage to kill Yama and absorb his energy, there's no guarantee I'll get a lot of it. Merely using telepathy on Beelzebub made him furious, so I dare not try using other magic on the other demons, even if just to 'examine' them. I could probably get a good feel for their power if I did that, but I run the risk of pissing them off.

Yeah. Best not to burn what bridges I've made. The demons are a useful ally, for now. What I need is to find a way to increase my power levels. Teleporting will eventually drain me, to say nothing of all my other abilities.

Absentmindedly, I decide to play around with my powers again. I aim my mind at a patch of the floor a dozen feet away. "**Sticks. Oil. Fire.**"

A moment later, there's a warm, cozy little fire burning and I lean forward to warm my hands. It's not exactly cold down here, but it's not hot either. I haven't felt the wind on my face since I woke up in the cryopod, and I rather miss it.

"**Extinguish.**"

The flames vanish instantly, and only half-charred twigs are left behind.

My abilities have a secondary limit. On top of the maximum energy I can hold, I cannot create anything complex if I can't picture exactly how it works. For some reason, creating oil, which has an unknown atomic structure, is doable, but imagining the inner workings of a clock or a gun is impossible for me.

Why the distinction? What separates the two of them? Is it merely enough to know that oil is greasy and flammable? What if I'm not actually creating oil, but just a "greasy flammable black liquid"? If they're the same, does it matter?

I chuckle to myself as another thought enters my mind. "**Lightsaber.**"

Nothing happens. This is my third limitation. It has to be a single word in order for the magic to work. In the case of this word, I'm unsure if it's because it's two words, or because lightsabers don't exist in reality. Then again, I don't know what a lightsaber's innards would look like, so that could be an issue too. After all, some double words will work fine.

"**Longsword.**"

A metal weapon shimmers before me for a split second before falling and clanging on the ground. I shoot a look around the corner at the women in the bathhouse, but I can't see either of them. They must be on the far end. I can't hear them, so they likely can't hear me.

I reach down and pick up the sword. To my annoyance, it wobbles quite a bit towards the far end of the blade, as if the metal is made of something akin to tinfoil, but perhaps a bit stronger. What is this? Iron? Steel? It can't be. Swords are supposed to be stiff and have little to no flex.

At least, I think so. I never studied anything about swords when I was in college.

Hm. What if... " **Reinforce.** "

The sword continues to wobble when I shake it, and I frown in response. " **Reinforce. Reinforce. Reinforce.** "

Nothing. The flex is still there. A thought occurs to me though, and I stand up and put a barrier in every direction to muffle the sounds around me. Taking aim at the chair I made, I swing at it with the sword, and the sword jams into the wood, getting stuck. After a moment of grunting, I pull it back out and swing again. Ten times, I swing the sword, and finally, I pull it back and look at it. The sword is not damaged in the slightest. Not even a scratch on its surface.

" **Stiffen.** "

Finally, the sword stops wobbling, and stands straight and true as I imagined it should.

It's as I thought. This is incredible. I can alter an object's properties, like the bed, bit by bit until it's made to my specifications, but I can also adjust its atomic composition. I reinforced the sword to the point where it isn't taking any damage, and now it doesn't wobble around either. Isn't it possible I could sharpen it dramatically? I made that boulder heavier in order to crush a commando...

Wait. Hold on a second.

Yama mentioned there are other wordsmiths. A whole army of them, even. I'm just one of many. Those commando suits were incredibly strong, durable to a ridiculous extent. The future might be advanced beyond anything I can imagine, but physics should still exist, right?

Perhaps those suits were reinforced with wordsmithing. If they were, and it certainly makes sense that they were... then I'm not as vulnerable as I thought.

Oho. I have an idea.

I glance up and down the hallways and back into the bathhouse to make sure nobody is around.

" **Suit.** "

In my mind, I picture a super thin green jumpsuit, one that covers me from head to toe. It's made of a practically weightless material, akin to nylon. The weakest form of protection I can think of. It probably wouldn't protect me from a bee sting.

The suit appears, and I alter it to fit myself, adding gloves, socks, and a mask that's super breathable. Quickly, I put it on after taking my clothes off.

I look stupid now. No doubt about it. If Lora and Hellga come around that corner now, they're going to get an eyeful of man-bulge. I'm sure they'll be thrilled, especially Hellga. Unfortunately for them, I plan to be done before then.

" Reinforce. Reinforce. "

I speak the words, over and over again. Soon, the suit hardens to a point where I can't move at all. I might have made the atoms too tight or something.

" Flexible. Flexible. "

I'm able to move again, and now I scratch at the material with my nails, only to find it feels like scraping a rock. I can't feel my finger at all.

Perfect.

This is exactly what I thought. I must be right. Those suits were reinforced artificially. Yama wasn't lying about other wordsmiths. The only options I can think of otherwise is that perhaps the armor is being manipulated at the atomic level, possibly by humanity's advancements in science... or by other forms of magic. I don't know if Yama can manipulate matter in the same way as me, but judging by Hellga's response to my wordsmithing, the answer would appear to be 'no.'

" Invisible. " Instead of aiming the word at myself, I point the energy at my new suit. It vanishes instantly, but I can still feel it around me.

I am surrounded by an invisible armor now. One that should render me, like those commandos, impervious to normal attacks.

Quickly, I put my regular clothes on, though I do notice that the armor dulls my sense of touch a bit. Still, it's nothing compared to when I use 'invincible.'

This is incredible. The next step is to enhance myself. Abilities are good and all... but can I upgrade my physical performance? My strength? Agility?

Hmm. That's a bad idea. I definitely want to try it, but if something goes wrong, I could burst a vein and die, or stress my heart to the point of cardiac arrest.

However... I could always test on someone else. In fact, I have just the perfect person for the job. I'm sure she'll be happy to help her master out.

I release the barriers and sit down in the chair for a while, and after ten minutes or so, I hear the sound of footsteps behind me. Finally, the two women step out of the bathhouse. Hellga, as always, looks like a walking pile of fecal matter, but... Lora is...

Well, she's beautiful. Her red hair is shiny now, not matted down with dirt and lord knows what else. I should have done this sooner. She's much easier on the eyes. As my eyes wander over her body, Lora glances down shyly to avert her eyes from mine.

Hellga, of course, is always on the offense. "Get her nice and cleaned up for you. No more lice. Happy? Can I go now?"

"Yeah. You can go. In fact, please do."

"Don't trip over yourself thanking me, human. I wouldn't want you to go to any trouble."

"I won't. Have no fear."

She rolls her eyes and shimmies away, grumbling to herself about ' *Shitty fucking humans* ' and soon, she's out of earshot. Good. Her voice is about as soft and pleasant as a wet fart on a hot summer's day.

Lora shuffles her feet slightly, and I suddenly remember what I was going to do. "Lora, now that you're cleaned up, we're going to do some training. Are there any wide open spaces in the area? Some room where I have lots of maneuverability?"

She finally looks at me and taps her chin for a moment before nodding slowly and pushing past me. She does that a lot. It'd sure be nice if she could just learn to say *yes* and *no*, and maybe even *please* and *thank you*. Probably a pipe dream.

We walk for over half an hour in total silence. This time, Lora doesn't turn right or left. She simply walks and walks until we arrive at what I can only presume is the end of Yama's property. Property? Maybe his domain? Whatever it is, the place he lives in is colossal.

And ugly. This demon is in serious need of an interior decorator. I'm getting so tired of black tiled walls. I've even taken to creating plants in my room, though they'll wither and die without sunlight.

Lora walks straight up to the wall and points, showing a vertical door handle bolted onto a wall with a seam running in the shape of a door. I reach forward and pull it open, right as some musky stale air blows into my face.

Ah... a warm breeze. It smells terrible, but soon the odor vanishes, and I'm surprised to see racks and stacks of armor, stuff that looks like it was made to fit men well over eight feet tall.

My eyes sweep the huge room, being several hundred feet deep and wide and thirty feet tall, it's the size of a college gymnasium and loaded with all sorts of implements. In fact, it reminds me of the room I saw with the girl encased in crystal.

I've heard mention of monsters in the labyrinth before. If I had to guess, the armor here is for orcs, or trolls maybe. I spot maces and clubs that are far too big and bulky for any common man to wield, along with black shields as tall as me.

The room itself is covered in the same dull tiling as everywhere else, yet I find myself wondering where the breeze comes from. There's no light anywhere inside, and it's mostly pitch black, but my eyes have grown far more accustomed to the darkness than I'd like to admit. I have a theory. Blaarjiim gave me his energy, so perhaps I gained other abilities from him as well. Seeing in the dark is likely to be one, though if there are others I have yet to see them.

Heh... maybe I should try messing with my vision later. So many possibilities, and so little time to test them out.

I step inside and grimace at the darkness. While I can see, Lora can't, and she seems nervous to enter the dark, ominous room.

" **Light.** " I speak, and an illumination appears everywhere in the room, coming from every surface, and yet nowhere at all. I make sure it's dim enough to not hurt my eyes, but I still wince when the lights first come on before my eyes finally adjust.

Lora follows along after me, glancing from this to that and even inside her knightly armor, she looks unintimidating as ever. I'm going to change that today.

"Lora. I've had you swinging your sword at walls for a while now. Do you think you're used to its weight yet?"

She nods.

"Good. Let's see if you've improved."

I aim my mind at an empty spot on the ground. " **Dummy.** "

A wooden dummy appears, and I alter its appearance a bit, so it's stuffed full of straw and has a superior sturdy base at the bottom. It shouldn't move around no matter how hard she hits it.

"Alright. I want you to swing your sword at the dummy. Try to hack it to pieces."

She gives me a confused look before raising the sword up in the air and swinging it straight down at the dummy. The sword somehow doesn't cut the dummy at all, instead deflecting off its left shoulder and falling down until it hits the ground. During the fall, Lora loses her grip on it and the sword falls uselessly to the side.

I shake my head slowly. "That was fucking pathetic. If I ever see something like that happen again... I'll pick a new slave. Now grab your sword, and try again."

She nods hurriedly and bends down to grab the sword, wobbling slightly as her clunky armor rubs together. She still hasn't developed the stamina for it.

When she stands, I take a few steps back and whisper under my breath. " **Strength.** "

Immediately, she shifts and her breathing becomes less labored, as if a weight was lifted from her shoulders. She lifts the sword up and the blade hums as it whistles through the air. Now she's holding it effortlessly. Indeed, she notices this and stares at the sword in confusion, wondering why it doesn't feel heavy anymore.

Without thinking about it, she steps forwards and swings down. This time the sword chops the dummy's left arm off effortlessly, but at the moment of impact, the sword splits in half and the pointy end flies directly at me.

Shit! Can't dodge!

The top half of the blade stabs my shirt and bounces off without any issues, landing on the ground at my feet. I quickly rub my chest and chuckle to myself. The armor worked. It was a solid idea. My T-shirt is ripped a little bit where the metal hit, but otherwise, I'm perfectly fine. Not even a bruise to be seen.

Lora, for her part, didn't even notice the goddamn sword breaking until a few seconds later, and she didn't see me nearly die. Once she does notice, I can almost see a question mark pop above her head as she examines the broken sword with a sad expression on her face.

"I boosted your strength. Don't worry about it. I'll make you another one. After this, I'm going to try raising your other abilities to see how you perform. I might even try boosting things that can't possibly be adjustable, but we will see."

Lora nods and sends an earnest look my way. Somehow... the expression on her face is different from usual. I almost feel a sort of confidence.

I create a new sword for her and then aim my mind at the dummy. " **Repair.** "

"Alright. Let's find out the actual limits of the human body."

* * *

Trade agreements. Dignitaries. A nonstop stream of pencil pushing. All I do is work these days. I'm stuck in an office doing the daily grind so that others can keep me out of the way. I know it, they know it... but alliances are tentative. Everything is held together by threads as thin as needles. All it will take is one sharp person with a laser torch at the right moment, and it all could come falling down.

Such is the life of a Supreme Commander.

My eyes glaze over as I read yet another one of the endless intelligence briefings. What do they want from me this time? Political support in the Raza sector. Why? Probably some royals on that planet think they're hot stuff, need to suppress a minor rebellion. That's the way it goes. Once humanity attained immortality, the threat of dying off was eliminated, meaning those in power stayed in power... forever.

Of course, that wouldn't stop eager young women and men from jockeying for position on their way up the corporate, political, and military ladders. Luckily, thanks to massive innovations in terraforming, we've been able to shove more and more people to different planets across the cosmos.

This means, sadly, that the pool of bickering whiners has merely spread itself around a far vaster, more confusing territory. Another fifty years and we're likely going to hit the two-thousandth planet that humans have infested. How am I supposed to manage all of these? Even the Supreme Commander of all humanity is far from infallible.

But then... *they* know that.

My thoughts are silenced as a soft tone rings throughout my office. It's quite a big space, with ample room to stretch as needed, and a nice big plexiglass window to see the city below me, but still... it's an office. I spend far too much time in here.

"Come in." The words loll out of my mouth, and I rest my chin on my fist while scrolling through the holopad's contents with my free hand.

The door opens, and to my surprise, it's not my assistant that enters but... someone else. A young blonde woman wearing a familiar red hypersuit. Her name evades me for a moment, but I whisper under my breath. "**Identify.**"

Amy Gutierrez. Right. She's a corporal in my personal neutralization force. How could I have forgotten? At least she doesn't hear me whisper and thus isn't offended that I forgot.

"Supreme Commander Hiro. I'm sorry for bothering you in your office." She pauses awkwardly and bows, and I can't help but notice there's a feeling of awe as she looks at me. I get that a lot, as I try to keep myself distant from the lower echelons.

"Corporal Gutierrez. Delightful to see you again. What can I help you with?"

My words are polite but strained. I feel like this is going to take a lot of time away from my work, meaning I'll get home even later than usual. I could just cheat and slow down time, but that wouldn't be fair to the others, I suppose. They have to put in their eight hours, and so do I.

I gesture to the seat in front of my desk, but she shakes her head. "I won't be here to bother you for long. I merely wanted... I wished to hand-deliver a report on an operation I conducted yesterday."

"Fantastic. Let's see it then." I can't help but let boredom creep into my voice as she pulls up a hologram with a privacy filter active. Her retinal chips allow only her to see its contents, and even to a Supreme Commander, the contents are blurred. Our chief engineer is really talented at creating new military tech.

A moment later, she swipes across the hologram, and an indicator appears on my holopad. It's an old-fashioned clunker from a few thousand years ago, but I can't stand the thought of getting implants so it will have to do for me. Plus, I'm just used to it at this point. I got tired of switching and upgrading tech over and over again, so the last major epoch, I put my foot down and said *no more*.

I skim the contents, but none of it looks very interesting. "Alright. Thank you for this delivery. Is there... anything else?"

An odd look passes across her face as she shifts her feet and glances out the window for a moment. Something's making her uncomfortable, but it would be rude to read her mind to find out what.

"Well, ah, it's about the mission. I guess you haven't heard anything about it yet."

"No. Just what I read in this report just now. Why? Did something happen?"

Her look of concern is starting to agitate me. *Spit it out! I haven't got all year!* I want to yell at her, but that's not how we do things anymore. Politeness and civility are at their most extreme these days.

"I'll just say it. Forgive me, Supreme Commander... we had to use the Containment Protocol during this mission. It was an emergency, and I did everything I could to-"

She stops speaking as a dark expression clouds my face. I can hear the exact instant the words catch in her throat.

"You used the... the Containment Protocol? Under whose authority?"

She bows her head, unable to look me in the eyes. "M-my authority, sir. It was requested during the mission, and I gave permission."

"Oh." I swallow hard and slowly set the holopad down, before nudging it away from myself. "I see."

"I know you must be... terribly displeased..."

"To say the least."

"Right. But it was an emergency, Supreme Commander. We had to rush."

I feel an edge in my voice I haven't felt in years. "You know *damn well* what the orders are regarding the use of that procedure. Authority must come from Central Command, directly through me. *Directly*, Corporal. No exceptions. Not one, not ever. Unless an Archdemon appears and is about to exterminate every human in the galaxy in seconds, there is *always* time to obtain permission for the protocol, and I am to always be present when it is used. Have I not made this clear before now?"

"Yes... sir. You've made it... abundantly clear." Her head hangs ever lower, but puppy-dog eyes won't work on me, nor will a simple apology.

"Good. Now I want you to explain to me what situation was so dire, what monster so threatening, that you had to override a direct edict from the Supreme Commander himself. I want to know in exquisite detail what could have been such an omnipresent threat that my presence wasn't required, but the Containment Protocol was."

Finally, she raises her head up and looks sheepishly at the desk, though she can't quite meet my eyes. "An S-class demon appeared, sir. I included all the details in my report. Flip to the, err, the section C, sub-header Gamma."

Silently, I use my telekinesis to navigate through the menus on my holopad until I arrive where she spoke of. I read the entry out loud to her. "The subject was a demon of unknown origin. It possessed diverse abilities, including telekinesis, instant teleportation without using hand-signs, invisibility, thermal evasion, and a devastating psychic attack that put three dozen commandos into a coma instantly."

I raise my eyes up after reading a bit more. "That's it? Certainly, a powerful foe, one I can understand why you were having trouble with, but the lives of three-dozen commandos do *not* give you the right to override imperial authority, and certainly not my direct orders."

She stiffens slightly before looking into my eyes again. "I understand, Commander, but the lives of my men were in grave danger. I made a judgment call, and I will take full responsibility for the fallout."

"How convenient." I lick my lips and turn to stare out the window to contemplate. "If only it were that easy. Simply override my direct orders, then claim responsibility, and only one person gets tarred and feathered. That way people can abuse the system."

"I didn't mean it like that." A hint of frustration enters her voice. "We all know the Containment Protocol has no downsides. It doesn't consume any extra energy. It allows us to

win against the demons all the time! Why can't we use it? Why can't we-"

"BECAUSE IT'S MY ORDERS! BECAUSE I SAID SO! THAT'S WHY!" I jump up, and the chair flies out from under me, banging on the hardwood floor below.

Amy shrinks back as a look of fear envelopes her face. A moment later I suddenly realize what just happened and I blink back rage before letting my shoulders slump a little bit. "Because... I said so. I have my reasons, Corporal. The top brass of the military wish for nothing more than to run in, guns blazing, and wipe out the demonic threat. The demons are a pittance... the demons are no threat to us. What are their numbers now, fifty thousand? Forty? The demons are the only thing preventing... preventing..."

My voice trails off as I realize she's shaking in fear slightly. "I'm sorry, Supreme Commander. I didn't mean to imply- I didn't mean to question your authority. You've done so much for us... I just thought that maybe..."

I raise a hand to cut her off. "Things are never so simple. I am disbanding your entire unit to make an example of those who disobey this policy. You will have your rank stripped, and will be removed from the United Military, effective immediately. There will be no other punishment."

"C-commander..." Her anger melts away as tears form. Her lip trembles softly. "I am sorry... I didn't mean for things to happen like this..."

"Few do. Go. I have work to return to, and now I have to schedule a meeting with the brass. This has quadrupled my work for the week."

Amy stares silently for a few long moments before bowing stiffly and marching towards the door.

"Wait, Gutierrez."

She halts and turns back to me.

"I... Thank you for your services. Despite this incident... you were exemplary in extinguishing the resistance on Goldesh III. I have not forgotten."

She doesn't respond but merely nods quickly before heading out the door.

It closes behind her with a faint *hiss*, and slowly I sink back into my chair, raising it up with my telekinesis.

My office is eerily silent afterward.

Slowly, I pull the holopad to myself and stare at it blankly, thinking about what led up to this moment.

A demon, S-class. These abilities are unheard of for demons to possess. Only a few demons had anything similar... and they're long since gone. Of the tens of thousands left, only a handful of demons could come close to this array of powers, and the chance of that happening is unlikely.

But if it was a demon that attacked the commandos... who was it?

I press a button on my holopad, and a video from Corporal Gutierrez's helmet camera plays back. Carefully, I examine the face of the demon caught on film.

Interesting. I'll have to investigate this myself.

Part 392b: Understanding

A pile of broken dummies sits crumpled in the corner, all of them hacked to pieces one by one. It's too much trouble for me to bother repairing them, so instead I've learned just to copy a functional one each time Lora destroys one. Takes less energy and time, too.

Sweat pours down every inch of her body. I deliberately lowered the temperature of the room so as not to overheat her, but any colder and I'll start shivering. She has long since tossed the armor to the side, now wearing only a loose fitting white undershirt and pants. I increased the size of her sword, as well as the weight, and now it's over five feet long and weighs two hundred pounds. It shouldn't even be wieldable by someone of her size. I'm about six foot tall myself, but she's only five foot, six inches.

Lora swings the awe-inspiring weapon down another time, cleaving the steel dummy in two effortlessly. Again, my automated arrow launcher fires a dozen bolts at her at once. She swings the sword with practice, smacking them out of the air, but fatigue is finally getting to her. One bolt wedges itself in between her two lowest ribs on her right side and she yelps in pain, dropping the sword and falling to the ground as she clutches the wooden bolt.

I teleport over to her in an instant, yanking the bolt out without hesitation. " **Heal.** "

She wheezes painfully as my magic does the trick, repairing the wound in less than a second. I place my hand on her shoulder to steady her posture, as this time it seems like she's finally at her limit.

Seventeen hours. Thanks to the word 'time', I was able to project a relativistic clock into my mind, telling me what time it was. It's like a super advanced version of human intuition, a perfectly tuned internal timer. Every time I think I may have wordsmithing figured out, more possibilities open up.

Lora looks exactly the same as she did when we first started, but now she's far stronger, faster, maybe even a little smarter. Perhaps not, but she's definitely honed some fighting instincts during this session.

I even took a chance and tried using *energy* to make her not fall asleep of exhaustion. However, I dare not use it too much. I feel as though it might have serious long-term issues, such as only artificially lengthening the amount of time she can stay awake.

Lora winces and clutches the place where the arrow impaled her, but it's fully healed up now. There isn't even a scar visible. Likely it's some form of phantom pain, a feeling that sticks around after a wound has healed.

"That's enough for now. I'm a little tired, and you're totally exhausted. I'll get you to your room, and we'll call it a day."

She smiles weakly and nods, but she's still holding the wound. I frown and stare at the spot, lifting her shirt up to get a better look. Nothing seems amiss, but perhaps I should take a closer look.

" **Vision.** "

I alter my eyesight, something I tried doing to pass the time while she trained. It seems that as I thought, as long as I mentally picture X-ray vision, or infrared vision, or anything else of the sort, I can adjust my sight to see what I want.

I stare at the wound carefully and raise an eyebrow with interest. There are dozens of wood splinters stuck under the surface, due to how I ripped out the arrow. No wonder she's still hurting.

" **Remove.** "

I aim my mind at all of the splinters at once, then heal the wound afterward. This time, Lora breathes a sigh of relief and sags forward, slumping against my chest. The pain must have been more than it looked, so at least I've taken a small burden off her.

I try to stand up, but as I do she clutches at my shirt for a moment before falling back and flopping on the floor. She's still breathing hard... perhaps a fever? I'm not a doctor, and I don't have a lot of experience so it could be anything.

The best thing I can do right now is getting her into bed. "Lora. Do you know where your room is?"

She blinks twice and shifts her head a little bit.

"I'll take that as a yes. I'm going to help you to your room. Just guide me as we go."

She barely even nods, and by now I see something is definitely wrong. Extending her limits might have put a toll on her body. " **Normalize.** "

No perceivable change happens, but her breaths do seem to come a little less ragged.

I aim my mind just outside this training room. " **Gurney.** "

A long, metal bed appears with wheels on the bottom. I alter it a few times to my specifications before using telekinesis to levitate Lora onto it, making sure to rest her on the padding so she won't fall off.

"You're lucky I am a compassionate master. You owe me even more after this."

I grumble under my breath, but start pushing her down the hall, closing the door behind me as I exit. This won't be the last time we come here. If she thinks this will end with just one day of training, she's wrong. Furthermore, I need to train myself as well. These tests have proven that I can increase my abilities, my body, even my vision can be augmented.

Speed, power, agility, reaction time, even making myself physically resistant or impervious to damage. Wordsmithing is total bullshit. It's like all the demons won the lottery, but only split twenty bucks among themselves, while I received a billion dollars. Why am I even worried about them? The only thing I need to do is ensure I've rooted out all the possibilities that my power gives me. Or at least most of them... there might never be a limit to what I can do.

Heh... it's funny. The real limitation of wordsmithing is how overwhelming the possibilities are. Humans often freeze when it comes time to make a critical decision. Usually, a timid or meek individual will only fight if it's the only option presented to him. Otherwise, when the time comes, he'll be paralyzed by indecision. This is why martial artists train for years to learn how to use their abilities because when the time comes, instinct will kick in and make their body move without being willed to do so.

"Do I turn right or left? Tell me where I have to go, Lora. Just point."

Lora shifts her right arm as we approach a corridor, so I turn right. Then she moves her left arm, so I turn left. This goes on for a long time as we navigate the maze of corridors.

As I push her along, using my telekinesis every so often to conserve my own energy, we pass room after room of slaves. The closer we are to the training room, the more sickly the slaves appear, but as we draw closer to my room and the central area, the better they look... relatively speaking. If I were a betting man, I'd wager that Yama or the demons that run his house put the weakest in the back, far away from the main room. Only the youngest, healthiest, most fit to serve slaves stay in the front rooms.

But why? Why even keep the weak slaves around? Yama has no interest in their welfare, and neither does Hellga. Then again... they can't be the only demons that live down here. I've seen perhaps three percent of this place. Other demons must live here, but where?

My mind flashes back, unbidden, to the memory I saw inside of Lora's mind. Demons devouring humans... perhaps back where the sick are kept, and as for the weak, the demons feast on them since they grow useless. Disgusting, if I have any say in it, but efficient. If one was to cull the weak, then demons have the right idea. This is all just guesswork on my part, but it makes sense. I haven't seen Yama or any other demon eating since I arrived, so their diet is mostly a mystery to me.

Soon, the corridors that blend together begin to look slightly familiar. I spot a scratch on a wall that reminds me of one I see around my room. It could be nothing, but even the smell around here is familiar. It's only once we walk past a doorway and I spot a mother and her daughter that I realize I recognize some of the slaves around here.

Hm. Come to think of it, a mother and her daughter? How could she have gotten pregnant? There isn't a man in sight anywhere. Perhaps demon and human biology are... compatible?

Unlikely. Unless that woman was captured recently and was pregnant already, or the demons seized her and her daughter at the same time, the likely scenario is she became pregnant down inside the labyrinth. I suppose even magic is a possibility since artificial fertilization seems beyond the demons' abilities to comprehend.

This place is a mystery. Things seriously don't add up.

Having rested for over a half hour while I pushed her around, Lora seems a little stronger than she was before. She points with a bit more vigor than expected, guiding me along the hallways until we arrive at one of the generic looking rooms that dot these corridors. Naturally, there is no door or covering to give the chamber any level of privacy. Three other girls are already inside resting, and I flinch at the condition of the room. Heat is leaking out of it, due to the small space and their body temperatures warming it up.

When I look into the room, all the slaves simultaneously turn in their beds to look at me, flinch, and quickly climb out of their bunk beds and bow their heads, as if waiting for orders. One of the girls can't even be twelve years old. Sad.

I help Lora off the gurney, and she leans against the doorway and breathes carefully.

"Will you be alright? Lora?"

She stares at me for several long seconds before lowering her eyes and nodding delicately.

I'm not really convinced. These quarters are squalid, to say the least. They can't be good for her to recuperate in.

I aim my mind at the gurney. " **Disappear.** " As I start to walk away, I feel something hold me back, and turn around to see Lora looking at me with an unfamiliar expression as she tugs at my shirt.

"Is there something you want?"

She lets go and blushes as if suddenly feeling self-conscious about her boldness.

I get it. I see clearly what is going on.

"This room won't do for my slave. Come with me. You will stay with me tonight."

I wrap one of her arms over my shoulder and start to pull her from the room, but she pulls away from me and stumbles back into the room, grabbing at something on the floor beneath one of the beds. I lean back into the room and watch silently as she pulls out a brass locket, cupping it in her hands before standing up and touching the chin of each other girl in the room.

A farewell, of some sort? The other girls continue to keep their heads bowed while I stand there, but one of them almost seems to nuzzle Lora's hand.

I don't know what their relationship is, but it appears to be a private moment. I step back and rest my back outside the room's wall, leaving the women to themselves. A half minute later, Lora steps out and brushes up against me, still clutching the locket in her hand.

What is the locket's story? It's not my business. If she wants me to know what it is, she will tell me when she learns to speak. I grab her arm and wrap it around my shoulder once again, as we head down the maze back towards my room.

She's just a slave. This is for her well-being, no other reason. It wouldn't do to have her get sick while I can't keep an eye on her.

That's all there is to it.

* * *

"Samuel. Lock the doors for me." I step out of my office, and the computerized voice responds from the ceiling.

"Have an enjoyable day, Supreme Commander! I hope to see you soon!"

"I hope not." I mutter under my breath and trudge down the hall, glad that my work is finally done for the day. Only a few more hours of daylight are left, and if I'm lucky it won't be raining when I leave.

The sterile white marbled walls loom in front of me as I walk down the hallway. Officers salute as I walk past, always stopping whatever they're doing to gaze at me in admiration.

Idiots. I hardly do anything important. I'm a figurehead at best.

"Commander." Yet another officer salutes and nods at me as I walk past.

"As you were."

I never return the salutes. I probably should, but it gets tiresome. These men and women always look up to me as if I'm a war hero. Hardly. Just let me head to the engineering bay, and I'll finally get to go home after this.

I step into the hover-shaft, and the male and female officer also riding it stiffen when they see me, saluting instinctively. "Supreme Commander! A pleasure!"

"Yeah. Same." I stifle a groan and salute them back, realizing it would be awkward if I didn't, given we'll be in this shaft for several minutes while it travels twenty miles down to the base of the building.

The woman's smile lessens a little bit. "Are you doing well, Commander Hiro? You look pale."

"I'm great. Just another day in the office. You know how it is."

"Hah! No kidding! You're an inspiration to us all! You never take a day off!" She beams a radiant smile at me and shoots a knowing glance at the other officer. Likely the two of them will get a real kick out of this, telling their comrades they spoke to the Supreme Commander in a hover-shaft. It's not like anyone will believe them. In a building with 250,000 personnel, the odds of running into me are astronomical.

I stare out the transparent walls of the shaft as we ride down the side of the command building. Other stratoscrapers are visible all around us, each filled with humans. How many live on this planet now? A trillion? Two trillion? We're going to need another planet soon to ship off half the population.

As high up as I am now, I see no greenery. Plants have no room to live, with how humanity has expanded aggressively. I suppose that's fine. We get our oxygen via advanced filtration nanobots in the atmosphere, and our food is created via a specialized array of reconditioning units. Energy is far from scarce, but as per an edict I passed, nothing shall go to waste.

We only get one Earth, after all. The homeworld is too precious for us to squander its resources.

The sky around us shifts colors as we enter the familiar blue hue that I've grown used to seeing. Staring up at the heavens, I spot the Moon in the sky. It's so much bigger when we're this high up... both halves of it are still floating in orbit, right where I put them. With my vision, enhanced via wordsmithing, I can just barely make out the colonies of Rigel IV on the closest point of Nixus, the brightest half of the Moon.

For some reason, the officers are interested in continuing the chat with me. The man clears his throat, perhaps a bit too seriously. "Err, Commander Hiro, I was just wondering, how close are we to eliminating the demons? I have a bet with my coworker."

"Too close." I mumble under my breath, and the man sends a look of confusion my way.

"I beg pardon?"

"Gambling is illegal during work hours, officer. Do you want to be written up?"

He turns white in the face. "Oh, ah, no. My apologies, Commander. I was just- that is..."

"I'll ignore it this once. Carry on." I continue to hold my posture up, noticing with a slight tinge of amusement that he is slumping meekly where he stands. Bad posture leads to misconduct, that's what I've learned over the years. I can tell immediately he's a slacker. Not like the woman next to him. She's perhaps a bit too enthusiastic, but I can tell by the medal on her shirt that she knows what work is.

It feels weird to leave the conversation like that, so I decide to make small talk with the woman. "The Badge of Courage. Bronze. How'd you get one of those?"

She blushes madly. "I served in the Assault Corps for a few centuries. It's nothing, really. Compared to my fellow officers, I'm not very distinguished."

"I see." I look up at the floor counter. Only a hundred floors to go. We'll be at the bottom in less than a quarter of a minute. A moment later, I do a quick probe of the surface of her mind, extracting the information regarding the incident. With her recalling the events in real time, it's quite simple. "It takes guts to pull a fellow soldier away from the frontlines under enemy fire. What's your name?"

"Elsa Parkson, Third Class. How do you know what I did to earn the badge?" She stares at me in awe.

"That's confidential. I'll see to it the brass bumps you up to silver." The door opens up, and I breathe a sigh of relief. The ride is over. "Have a nice day, Miss Parkson. You as well, Mister Andino."

As I walk off the elevator, I hear the man whisper to her. "How did he know my name? I never even mentioned it."

I smile for a moment, where they can't see it. I suppose it won't hurt to drum up the intrigue of the Supreme Commander just a little bit. It's all I can look forward to these days.

Continuing onward, I walk down the halls until I arrive at the engineering bay. The door opens automatically as the ceiling scanners read my biological imprints. Another male computer voice greets me. "Good afternoon, Supreme Commander! How may I assist you today?"

"I've got things under control. Thank you, Samuel."

I walk past personnel dressed in lab coats and military officers dressed in full uniform as they talk about this and that. Finally, I spot the woman I've been looking for. "Marie. I need to speak with you."

A sultry redhead turns around as I speak, pressing her thick glasses up her nose. "Jason! Do you need something?"

"I need to borrow you for a few minutes, privately. Something came up earlier."

She examines my expression for a moment. "Can it wait? I'm working on something myself."

"Now would be best."

She rolls her eyes, the only person among all my personnel who would disrespect me like that. I wouldn't have it any other way. "Fine. Gods. Let's go to my office."

I tilt my head towards the door on the other side of the room. "This'll take a few minutes at most. You'll be fine."

A minute later, she closes her office door behind us. "Samuel, privacy please."

The computer follows her orders silently, and she pulls out a cigarette, lighting it as she leans against her desk. After taking a long drag, she exhales and smiles. "Lord, that never gets tiresome. What do you want?"

I lick my lips, deciding to break the news in the simplest manner possible. "There is another wordsmith. The demons have him."

She doesn't even blink. "Oh. That sucks."

"That sucks? Marie, are you kidding me?! He could undo all my work. He already took down three dozen commandos in seconds. The troops were so panicked they overrode my orders and used the Containment Protocol! This is serious."

She sighs. "It's always serious with you. Look, I told you it was possible another wordsmith might show up someday. The powers of the Hero can appear in mysterious ways."

"Bullshit. That doesn't add up at all!" My voice strains and I rub my temple slowly. "Heroes don't just fall out of the ether, Marie."

"I didn't say that. I'm just saying... things can happen that you don't anticipate." Her voice trails off, and she stares at my chest as if looking through me at something unseen. "I wonder if..."

"You wonder what? Do you know something?"

She shakes her head slowly. "No, it's probably nothing. Just my overactive imagination."

I simmer slightly as she continues to stare at my chest with that same vacant expression. I can always rely on Marie to never hold anything back. Unlike the rest of my personnel, she treats me as if my authority doesn't matter, but that also means I can always get honesty out of her when others will lie to protect their dignity.

But this time is different. She's not telling me something. "Marie, what do you know? Do you have an idea who this demon is?"

She quickly meets my eyes again. "Demon? Why would you ever assume it was a demon?"

"The video files shows a demon. I assumed it was logical." I hold up my holopad and play the video. She stares at it skeptically.

"You and I both know it would be trivial to mask your identity with wordsmithing. If this really is a wordsmith, and you've shown no proof of that, then there's no reason to believe that's a demon."

"So it's not a demon, then? That's... something to go on."

She shakes her head quickly. "I'm not saying he isn't a demon, I'm just saying he isn't necessarily a demon. Could be human, could be demon. It could go either way. Magic is like that."

"Yeah. Magic is like that." I echo her words, feeling more anger building. "If he's a wordsmith, what should I do?"

She smirks. "You're the all-powerful Supreme Commander. Crush him with a boulder or something. Then he'll be out of your hair."

I can't help but curl my lip up. "Marie. That's disgusting. I could never do something like that."

"Right, right. You're a real pacifist, Jason." She stares at me for several long seconds, with an expression on her face I haven't seen in a long time. It looks almost like... distrust. "That's what I like about you... compared to the others."

"The others?"

"Nothing." She taps her cigarette into the ashtray. "Look, I'll work on something. We'll try and capture him non-lethally, alright? Will that suit your fancy?"

"Sure. Whatever. No killing. You know how I-"

"Yes. Jesus, I know. Calm your horses." She stands up and takes one last puff before smashing the cigarette into the tray. "God, I love these. Do you know how hard it is to get hold of cigarettes anymore? Had to make myself a specialized replicator just for the job, and the flavor tastes like shit. I've taken to growing tobacco in my apartment just so I can roll my own."

As she walks toward the door, I stare at her. "That's illegal."

"Piss off. What are you going to do, fire me? Throw me in jail? Get out of here so I can get back to work."

"Of course not." I walk past her out of her office. "I'm just letting you know."

"Thanks. What a friend." The door closes behind her, and Samuel locks it securely. "Seriously though, I'll solve this crisis. Happy?"

I grunt in response. "Yeah. Thanks. You're the best. I need to get home. Sarah's waiting for me."

"Tell her I said hi. Or don't. I don't really care." Marie walks away, making sure she has the last word as always.

What a woman.

I leave the building and send a notification to my assistant, Stephanie, telling her to arrange a meeting first thing in the morning with the district leaders of Earth. Maybe she'll go the extra mile and get the Local Cluster's leaders on the holographic channel. I'm probably asking too much.

As I step into the hall, even more people salute me and I press past them, barely acknowledging their presence. The tedium never ends.

I'd kill for a routine life, one without the burden of leading a galaxy.

Part 393b: Looming Shadows

What? Where did you go? Hero? Hero!

You can't just run away! What does 'rewind' do?! What does that even mean?!

Come back and face me! How dare you let them die and then flee for your life! Get your ass back here!

You're not a hero after all... you're just a coward!

Goddamn you! Goddamn you to hell!!

* * *

My eyes bolt open, and I jerk up, blinking rapidly. What was that? A dream? A nightmare? The details are already hazy.

Yeah. Just a nightmare. I don't even remember what it was about.

I glance to my side and stare at the woman sleeping beside me. She isn't wearing anything, of course, because that would defeat the point. She was too tired for us to do anything last night, as was I, but the warmth of a female beside me was quite welcome.

Even so, I can't help but stare at her back. Long since scarred-over marks are all across her spine and shoulders, likely from a whip or a lash of some sort. Without a voice, she cannot tell me what caused the marks, but I can manage an educated guess. My only real question is whether the demons did it for pain, or for pleasure.

Psychopaths. The demons have no sense of decency, even among themselves. I've come to realize this over the last several days. A demon will betray one of his own kind if he has something worthwhile to gain, but likewise, he holds no feelings for another species at all.

I aim my hand at her back. " **Heal.** "

Nothing happens. The scars stay exactly as they were. I wondered if that would be the case, and now my suspicions have been confirmed.

It seems unlikely that wordsmithing can't remove her scars, but perhaps it's better this way. If I remove the scars or the memories that caused them, Lora will lose something important that makes her, *her*.

Memories are important. They shape a person as he or she grows, reminding them of great successes and painful losses. An individual who is burned is more likely to be cautious around fire, just as a girl tortured by demons is sure to always be on her guard when around them.

I turn away from Lora and climb off my side of the bed. " **Wear.** "

My invisible armor appears over me, which fills me with a sense of security. I feel naked and defenseless without it now. My body is incredibly fragile, and all it would take is a stray bullet or a blow to the head to end me. But with this suit, a tank could shoot me at point blank range and I'd probably survive. Maybe.

I'd prefer not to test that out. I pull my pants up in one motion, hopping as I yank to get them on quickly. My shirt gets tossed on next, and I aim my mind at them both. " **Clean.** "

The best part about wordsmithing is all the tiny details. I don't have to waste time doing boring things, I can make them happen instantly.

My stomach growls and I consider going out to the dining room to eat, but that isn't really necessary anymore. " **Pizza. Soda. Napkins.** "

A piping hot meal pops out of the great beyond, appearing upon a table I shoved off to the side of the room. The soda is... I don't know what, exactly, but it tastes decent enough. The pizza has everything on it, and tastes better than any I've eaten before it. The meat is cooked to perfection, and the smell is like heaven.

As I chow down, I hear a rustling behind me. I turn back to see Lora sitting up in bed, pulling the covers over herself and staring at the food in confusion.

"Oh, this is pizza. Would you like some? It's very good."

She doesn't nod or shake her head, but instead stares at it silently. The smell probably woke her up, plus my loud lip-smacking. I can't help it, I just love the stuff. For some reason, I am careful to pick off the chunks of chicken spread all over, but that's beside the point.

" **Plate.** " A flat white ceramic dish appears in the air, landing silently in my hands. I pull two slices off and walk over, handing her the plate. "Here. Eat. You'll love it."

She takes the plate from me but continues to stare at it silently, as if unsure what to do with it.

"What's the matter? It's good food. Look, just eat it like this." I grab a slice from my own plate and bite into it, showing her how to do it.

She nods silently, and delicately picks it up, wincing as she realizes the pizza is hot. "Blow on it. You might burn yourself otherwise. Nothing like scalding hot cheese to ruin the roof of your mouth."

She puckers her lips, blows on it, then delicately nibbles at the very edge of it. The movement almost reminds me of a chipmunk. Immediately, she pulls back and chews silently. Only then

does something happen that even surprises *me*. She starts to cry and quickly turns away to wipe at her eyes.

"Are you okay? Is it... too hot?" What is she crying about? It's just pizza, for god's sake.

A moment after she finishes drying her tears, she completely ignores me and stuffs the entire slice into her face. She devours it with such gusto that I lean back in my chair and stare in awe. The ruthless efficiency with which she envelopes the cheesy bread in her mouth is almost enviable.

After she does this, her eyes open wide and she finishes off the crust, and the second slice follows seconds after. Only once she is done does she stare at the plate with a sad, empty expression. She smacks her tongue around inside her mouth, as if to get a good feel for the organ.

"Do you uh... want more? I can make as much as you want."

As if lighting a fire inside her soul, the woman nods ferociously and smiles giddily as she holds the plate up. She opens her mouth as if to speak, but all that comes out is a guttural grunt.

I can't help but smile at her eagerness. "Fine, fine. Here, have more. What a pig."

She continues to gorge herself on the pizza, and finally something clicks in my mind. "I wonder what sort of food the slaves eat here usually. Have you ever eaten anything like this before?"

She pauses mid-bite to look at me with a sad expression before shaking her head.

That's unfortunate. Still, I don't know what all is going on down here. It's not like I care about the slaves or their lives or anything... some people are born with much, while others are born with little. That's just the way the world goes. People have to forge their own path with the odds they've been given. Sometimes people will even break free and go on to better things, improving the lives of their families.

But there's no such thing as equality. It can't exist. If the rich really cared and wanted equality to exist, they would have to give up their fortunes and live meager lives among the peasants. Some may actually do that, but most would not. And as long as even a plurality don't, there will always be a lower class with less than others around them.

But... then again, does it have to be that way? I have Wordsmithing, a power that can change the universe. What if I truly equalized things with my power? Would everyone be happy?

Of course not. The rich, now reduced to the same level as those they once sneered at, would curse my name for all eternity. I can't make everyone happy. For now, it's best to focus on me.

And this woman, as well. If her life is improved incidentally... well, that's just a bonus.

Finally, Lora reaches her limit and halts mid-bite before leaning forward and clutching her stomach. "Dumbass. If you eat too much, you're going to barf." I walk over and take the plate from her, and while she seems as if she might panic that I'm taking the food away, she finally bows her head and accepts my decision. "Relax. I can make more later when you're not about to die from overdosing on pepperoni."

I scratch my chin before tossing her clothes to her. "Put these on. We're going to walk off all that food and get back to training. Looks like you're feeling better." I grin evilly at her. "And if you thought I didn't notice you faking exhaustion yesterday, you're wrong. I'm going to work you twice as hard today. We're going to train together."

She doesn't seem sad about this, as if she's glad I was smart enough to figure it all out. She climbs out of bed and puts her clothes on, and I lean on my chin and watch as she does. "Call it curiosity, but I've been wondering about those scars on your back. Maybe someday when you get your squawk-box working, you can tell me who did that to you."

She blushes and turns her back away from me before pulling her shirt on.

"I'll make sure whoever did it pays dearly."

* * *

The door hisses open, and I adjust my uniform's collar as I step in. Immediately, the table with fifty seated at it shifts as everyone stands up at once. "All rise! The Supreme Commander has entered!"

I walk in and shake hands with a few of the people nearest my seat. "Mister Feldmann, Mister Ducat, Miss Suharto... a pleasure to see you again." I sit down quickly and only once I do does everyone else in the room follow suit. I quickly scan the faces present, using my acute mental reflexes to identify everyone all at once. There are many people present here. Not just the various district leaders of Earth, but the de facto president of the Martian colony, the Navy commander for this sector, and even a surprise guest.

A hologram comes online in one of the seats nearby, just five seats to my left, and everyone gasps audibly. I, however, manage to be courteous.

"Founder Unarin. I was not expecting a Volgrim representative, and certainly not the highest member of your... species. It is good to see you again."

He blinks slowly, almost as if he's bored, before he turns to look at me. His modulated voice isn't as crisp as it could be, and there is a several second delay from when his mouth moves and the sound appears, but even magical relays have their limits.

"Supreme Commander Hiro. I was called, and so I have come. Why are you surprised?"

I force a smile through. "I must have forgotten. No worries. I assume things are going smoothly in the Volgarius sector?"

He flicks his gaze around the table. "Yes. The Vesperian mining is moving forward as expected. We are contributing the required amount as per the treaty." He takes a slow breath. "The same cannot be said for the human colonies in Sector Lirus. We have been waiting for our portion of the Trifrancium that we were promised."

My smile weakens as I shoot a glare over at a woman on the other side of the table. Aleana Masri is the leader of that sector, and she's noteworthy, but only for how poor she is at keeping with a schedule. "My apologies, First Founder. I will make sure to rectify that situation by the end of the day."

She doesn't even look at me, instead opting to examine her nails. That worthless- no, it's fine. Unarin has been very good at cutting us some slack. As we are the top rulers among our species, I am certain he understands the difficulties of managing a vast empire, though his is far smaller than mine.

"I called this meeting today to discuss our official war policies. Specifically with regard to the demon infestation and how we can... be proactive."

General Feldmann, the person who sits immediately to my right, smiles wildly. "Are you finally authorizing a full invasion? We can wipe out all the demons by the end of the month. Just give me the order, Commander Hiro."

I lower my eyes slightly. "About that. Actually, I wanted to remind people of our official policy regarding the Containment Protocol. Is everyone familiar with it?"

A chorus of grumbling and whispering sounds off across the table. A man seven seats down to the right groans more loudly than the others. "Yes, Supreme Commander. We are never to use it without your explicit authorization. That is, despite all the wonderful benefits it has and how easy it is to combat demons."

His sarcastic tone draws slight nods from people to either side of him and across the table.

"Yes, that is correct. Thank you, General Zhao. I'm glad to hear you haven't forgotten. However, it came to my attention yesterday that during an operation in the labyrinth just this last week, one of the field commanders overrode my direct authority and used the Containment Protocol against a single demon. I assume everyone here read the cliff notes prior to this meeting?"

To my surprise, every person in the room shoots a look of confusion at one another. "Really? Not one of you read them?"

Zhao holds his holopad up slowly. "I have no such document on my reader."

Other people nod silently, and I curse my assistant under my breath. Stephanie always manages to get the work done, but she messes up the important details.

"It isn't imperative for you all to have read them, I suppose, but I'll explain in brief. Corporal Gutierrez, the leader of the Golden Commandos, overrode my direct orders and did this in order to suppress a single enemy combatant. As I have said before, no matter how powerful the enemy, I am always to be asked before--"

Another person in the room, perhaps bolder than most, interrupts me. "Gutierrez? Amy Gutierrez? Wasn't she instrumental in the suppression effort on one of our colonies?"

I stare the woman down who spoke. "Yes, she was. In the future, refrain from interrupting me when I am talking, General Makuba."

She quickly looks away meekly, and I stuff down a ripple of anger. It won't do to look weak here. If I let just any bureaucrat talk over me, it makes me sound like a weak and ineffectual leader. Considering the size of the empire, that simply won't do.

Before I can speak again, Zhao takes my moment of silence as the perfect time to speak. "She sounds like a fool, but what does this have to do with us? I got my hopes up thinking we would finally be given the order to crush the demons."

Another man speaks up. "Zhao, you know we can't do that. The demons are sentient creatures. If we kill them off, won't we be just as bad as they are?"

"Fine talk for a desk jockey! I've seen those creatures in action, Danis, and they are truly a fearsome enemy! What if they get wise and attack a fledgling colony? Do you want another disaster like the one on Alnaru? Ten million dead civilians! Do their lives mean nothing to you?"

"Of course the demons attacked back! We've been eradicating them for millions of years! You can't poke a dog with a stick and not expect it to bite back! Especially after you've poisoned its water and turned it feral!"

"A dog is a dog, Admiral Danis. The demons are feral by nature. Whether we left them alone or not, they would continue to seek our destruction! Have you forgotten how their leaders repeatedly turned down our generous offers for peace?"

"Generous?! What a joke! You wanted them to give up everything! They would be less than slaves, forced to mine and work for us! It's not peace if one side is in servitude to the other!"

Finally, I pound my fist on the table. "Goddamnit! Both of you, stop your bickering! I've heard enough!" The room grows silent as the two men snarl at each other silently before leaning back in their chairs.

It takes me several moments to steady my shaking hands, as well as my voice. "This is more important than you know. I am going to hunt down the demon that attacked my private guard. The monster is ranked S-class and is extremely dangerous. It managed to neutralize three dozen men and women all at the same time. However, I brought everyone here today to reiterate, yet again, that my order stands firm. I must *always* be petitioned before deploying the Containment Protocol."

Zhao, the smug bastard, leans forward again. "You still haven't told us why, Supreme Commander. Why can't we deploy such an effective weapon? We've had this in reserve for a million years, if not two or three, and yet you still won't allow us to deploy it. Does it have a downside? Is there some unknown cost that we haven't considered?"

I bite my lip for a moment before realizing how that might appear to others in the room.

I can't tell them the truth. If the demons are eliminated, the peace will fall apart. Only the threat of monsters tearing humans apart keeps them in line. Even then, many humans have forgotten the boogeyman. Demons are so effectively contained that they haven't a prayer of causing real havoc anymore. And the two billion forced to stay in work camps... they don't exist, as far as the public knows.

Heh... and that's not the only reason.

"There's no hidden cost, General. However, if you believe that you are not able to suppress the demonic threat without using this tool, I might be able to find someone who would be more suitable for your position. I had thought it would be a trifle for a military leader of your talents."

I wipe my lips to hide a smile as the smug prick gnashes his teeth together. "No, no, you are right, Commander Hiro. I... forgot my place."

"Mmm. Please ensure that it doesn't happen again." I turn back to the Volgrim who has sat and watched the meeting silently. "Have you any closing thoughts, esteemed guest? Perhaps any insight on the matter?"

He stares at me and I feel a slight chill breathe down my neck. "No. Your tactic is quite sensible. Truly, I understand what you are hoping to accomplish. As it is, I enjoy watching humans interact. Your emotions provide me with a real appreciation of how Volgrim loyalty never wavers. Humanity might stand to learn from our kind."

Finally, I flash a genuine grin. The seriousness of the meeting seems to have worn off now, thanks to his comment. "Thanks, but no thanks, Unarin. I like my emotions, just the way they are. Live long and prosper, or whatever you say."

Unarin doesn't return the smile. "I contemplate, and I comprehend. Farewell, humans."

He vanishes a moment later, and a sigh passes around the room as even I feel a sense of relief. It's always weird speaking to those aliens. They don't look quite like us, yet they do. It's unnerving.

As if reading my mind, one of the women at the table pipes up. "Did we ever manage to trace our genetic lineage compared to the Volgrim?"

She gets a response instantly. "Yes. The results were inconclusive. We share 95% of our DNA, but it's unclear whether we originated from them, or vice versa. Common sense speaks otherwise."

I decide to put an end to the meeting. I stand up, and everyone else does as well. "Ladies. Gentlemen. I thank you for coming. I trust I won't have to bring up this topic of discussion again?"

Everyone shakes their heads and I sigh once more. "Dismissed."

I walk out the door and Admiral Danis power-walks up to me, shoving the glasses up his nose. "Supreme Commander! That was an enjoyable meeting, as usual!"

Huh? It was? I shake his hand and groan silently to myself. This guy always wastes my time, after every meeting. He's such a goddamn kiss-ass.

"I'm in a rush today, Danis. Maybe some other time."

A flash of shock passes over his face, but he shakes it off quickly. "That's fine, not a problem! Look, I just wanted to say, I appreciate your protection of the demons. Truly, it is good that you are not allowing us to sink to their level. You are an inspiration to everyone!"

The room behind me is full of people milling about, chatting with each other loudly, so luckily nobody hears this idiot talking. I pull him aside and put my hand on his back.

"Danis... things are never what they seem. Please do not infer such a simple-minded assessment of my opinion. The situation is far bigger than anyone here will ever understand."

He nods slowly, as if I gave him some awe-inspiring nuggets of wisdom. "Of... of course. My apologies, Commander Hiro. Have a safe day."

I shake his hand again and turn away, my eyes rolling up into my skull of their own accord. I leave him behind without saying anything else. The last thing I want is to encourage the bastard to talk some more.

I walk over and board the hover-shaft, wincing inwardly as I spot two officers already on board. "Hello, Supreme Commander!" They both salute and smile.

Great. Another long ride. Maybe I should just teleport today.

Part 394b: Snap

"Swing at me. I'll deflect it." I hold my sword up, and Lora watches nervously as she raises her weapon. She takes a step forward and then pauses, and I groan in response.

"Come on, Lora. If you're too afraid to use your weapon, you'll be useless in battle. Do you want me to get rid of you and pick another slave? Attack me, already."

I can see a raging battle inside of her head as she faces off against me in my home-made arena. With a dim illumination coming from all around, my newly enhanced hearing allows me to hear all sorts of things, including the scurrying of a cockroach a few feet away, a dim resonance of sorts from the living areas outside, and other indescribable sounds that I mentally force myself to block out.

To say nothing of my sense of smell. I had to remove that improvement because some of the odors in Yama's domain were overpowering to the point of nausea. I suspect that even in the case of traditional human society, too much of a good thing would be information overload.

Lora, however, never complained about anything. I noticed her wince whenever she struck the dummy earlier, likely because of the sharp, ringing noise it made, but she appeared to grow used to it after a while.

Lora continues to stare at me for several seconds, before shifting uncomfortably. She doesn't like the idea of swinging at me. It's obvious.

"Is it guilt? I won't harm you if you attack me. This is practice. That's what you're supposed to do!" Finally, I sigh and crick my neck. "On second thought, I'll do the attacking. You just block as best you can. I'll go easy at first and increase the pace as time goes on."

She nods at me, but the solemn expression on her face never leaves. She reaches up and pulls a few strands of her red hair out of her eyes before firmly grasping her sword once more. After I berated her before about dropping her sword, she's never done it since. Good. It shows she can be taught.

I lunge forward and swing my sword down at her in a rather clunky motion, just to test her, and she bats my sword deftly to the side. "Nice! Keep it up!"

Then I spin around and swing sideways at her kidney, and once again she catches my blade with hers and pivots it away, knocking the tip down to the ground. Still, she never takes the initiative to attack, and she seems quite content to do nothing but defend.

Not good enough. She can't resist forever. Her opponent might wear out eventually, but she will as well. Finally, he who strikes first is more likely to land a damaging or killing blow, while a defender will only do so if they use their opponent's movement against them. She's far too amateur for that to happen, though I am as well. In truth, we both require training.

As I swing my blade at her time after time, a humorous thought occurs to me. Training with swords is probably useless. In an age of ranged attacks, such as blasters and magic, a sword seems quite primitive and worthless. Indeed, with enhanced strength, I could hack a man to pieces if I get up close, but a blaster is a much more effective weapon in the long run. Not to mention that no matter how strong, sharp, and durable the sword, it's probably going to be worthless if I face off against those Golden Commandos with their ridiculous armor once again.

Of course, I have planned a few counter-measures for if I see them next time. I just hope I won't have to test them out. They are truly frightening opponents, even for me.

I stab forwards at her and Lora bats my blade away again, but suddenly she stiffens and glances at the doorway. I shoot a glance over there, but I see and hear nothing. I turn back to her. "Focus on the fight, Lora. What happens out there is none of your concern."

She nods absentmindedly, but her guard is still lowered. I decide to teach her an example and jump at her, swinging my sword down towards her left shoulder. She jerks back in surprise and deflects my blow just in the nick of time, but squeaks in surprise.

I can't help but chuckle. "Haha! An enemy won't wait for you to stop being distracted in a fight! Come on, take the initiative! Take a stab at me!"

She surprises me by gritting her teeth and shaking her head, even as she shifts back into her guard stance. "Oh really? You would tell your master 'no'? Then I am going to stop going easy on you. You don't have the *right* to tell me no. Everything I've done so far has been for your welfare. You'd best not be ungrateful."

Without waiting for a response that I know won't come, I dash forward, and this time put my back into a flurry of strikes, stabbing, swinging, and even kicking once or twice. Lora astounds me, however, by deflecting all of my attacks easily, even as she keeps occasionally glancing at the doorway.

"Focus on me! Stop looking outside!" I switch up my approach and quietly wordsmith for a split second on myself. It's time to show her the consequences of being absentminded during a battle. "**Strength.**"

I feel my power rise roughly fifty percent, which is a substantial number considering we've been about equal this whole time.

The dumb woman continues to stare at the entrance, and I take my chance, lunging forwards and putting all my power into a downward slash aimed directly at her neck. By my calculations, if she fails to dodge, it will just barely glance downwards on her highly reinforced shoulder armor, and may just break her shoulder. Easily fixable.

My swing is so powerful that the air seems to light on fire for a moment, and at the last second she shifts her weight and swivels her body to the side, leaving my defenses open. With a flick of movement, she swings her sword up and smashes my weapon out of my hands, sending it careening through the air until it plunges into the ceiling. I, however, fall roughly on my chest and blink in stunned silence.

"Whoa."

I lay on the floor for several long moments as I try to understand what just happened. Finally, I can process everything, and I stand back up and stare at my blade, now embedded in the canopy. "Well done... I underestimated you. For all my talk about being on guard, it was you who surprised me."

I turn and smile at her, only to feel my entire expression slump as she once again stares at that goddamn doorway.

"Hah... fine. We'll call this good for today. We've been here for about six hours. That's plenty of training."

She barely even acknowledges my words. I want to ask what she's looking at, but she won't be able to respond anyway. Or maybe she just doesn't want to. I wonder what it will take for her to learn to speak. I should try training her at some point.

I reach up with my mind and yank my weapon from the ceiling with telekinesis, then stab it into the ground. I take Lora's weapon from her, even as she mostly ignores me, and thrust hers into the ground, alongside mine.

"I don't know what's bothering you, but obviously we've done enough here. Come on, let's go."

I walk towards the doorway but sigh as I realize she isn't following, but is instead standing in that same spot. "Come on, Lora. Let's go."

She persists for several long seconds before taking a tentative step forwards, and then another, and another... after several grueling seconds, she walks over to my side. She loops her arms around mine and presses up against me, and only now do I realize she's shaking.

"What's wrong? Are you scared of something?"

She nods.

"Well, don't be. I'll protect you from... whatever it is." I walk along with her and slam the doors shut behind us as we leave, half expecting to see Yama or one of the other demons standing outside. That does not turn out to be the case.

We walk along the corridors, heading back to the main room, and her shaking grows more intense. She begins to subtly pull on me to slow me down as if we're approaching some big, final boss.

Frankly, I'm getting nervous myself. Something has Lora spooked, and her jitters are transferring to me. I want to smack her and tell her to calm down, but at the same time we're in a place with powerful demons roaming around. She might have a good reason to be terrified. Maybe I shouldn't have left the swords behind. In any case, they probably aren't going to be much use against whatever it is up ahead.

We continue to walk forwards, and her constant pulling on me becomes a real struggle as she shakes her head over and over. Finally, I pull my arm away from her and wrap it around her back, gently pushing her forwards. "There's n-nothing to be afraid of. Calm down, Lora. No demon will hurt you as long as I'm here."

And then I hear it.

In the distance... a strange sound, like a grunting noise. Over and over, in a steady rhythm. She's trying to pull me away into one of the side corridors to take a detour back to my room, but I won't have it.

That sound is not from a demon. It's a human. A male, to be precise.

Was she able to hear this back at the training ground? Is her hearing that much better than mine? Our abilities should have been roughly equal, but perhaps there's something more at work here.

She ducks away from my arm and pulls around behind me, dipping down, as if to make herself smaller. I gently reach back and hold her hand, even as I continue walking forward, keeping my pace slow, so she doesn't get spooked.

Eventually, she can't take it anymore and pulls away, dodging into a side pathway and cowering. I start to say something, only to look through an open doorway and spot several other slave girls flinching against the far corners of their room and staring at me with terror in their eyes.

Somehow, whoever is up ahead, whoever this man might be, he scares these girls more than even the demons. It's a primal fear, one I haven't seen at any point in my life.

"Stay here, Lora. I'll take a look."

I whisper into the darkness, but I know she can hear me. A quick glance over my shoulder and I see her crouching down, barely peeking around the corner. She nods quickly, almost like a wife when there's a burglar in the house. *Grab the shotgun.* That's what her expression says to me.

I swallow hard and continue walking. Soon, the muffled grunting is much more audible, and I can hear many other things. The sound of creaking metal. The ground being scraped by heavy boots. The sounds also reek of 'moisture,' a sort of sloppiness that upsets my stomach.

I arrive at a junction just before the room where the noises are coming from, and I can finally tell what's going on. It is, without a doubt, the sound of two people having intercourse. The woman, however, is silent. Every so often, the man coughs and mumbles something in a manner I can only describe as a drunken stupor. I take a few steps towards the doorway and frown, just as a chill shoots down my spine. This is Lora's old room, where her fellow slave friends live.

I quickly walk up and turn around the corner. Immediately, I take everything in. An older woman, possibly twenty-five, lying motionless on the ground. Her body is stiff, and she's lying at an unnatural angle. Her neck has marks on it as if she's been strangled. My enhanced sight stares at her dispassionately, observing her nude body and how the skin is turning blotchy.

She's dead. She's been dead for a while, at least an hour or two. There are marks all over, as if... as if the man beat her after he killed her. Several spots on her face and stomach are purple and blotchy, where the blood has pooled.

And the man, his back is turned to me. Another of Lora's previous roommates, the younger woman, possibly a year or two older than Lora herself, is chained to the bed. She is completely silent, and her eyes are closed. I can't see much of her behind the foul creature blocking my view, but I don't want to. What I can see is already gruesome enough. I close my eyes and take a deep silent breath, even as my enhanced hearing fills in one detail I'd rather not know. There's only one heartbeat in this room. Both girls are dead.

"Just... what exactly do you think you're doing?" The words hiss from my mouth as I open my eyes and gaze emotionlessly at the man.

The bastard pauses his thrusting to jerk his head up and look around, before turning back to look at me. "Wait your turn, you fucking bashturd! Give ush shome privashy!"

The man is dressed in an unfamiliar military garb. It's navy blue, and he has three large stars pinned to the front of his jacket. His pants are carelessly tossed off to the side of the room, but he continues to wear his coat for some unknown reason. I don't recognize the fashion from anywhere, but he's a clean-shaven man, seeming to be of British descent. His hair is matted

down with sweat, turning what otherwise might look like a decent family man into a drooling psychopath.

He immediately ignores me and goes back to thrusting, so I cough loudly. "Explain yourself!"

There's no way to save these women. But now my rage is overcome with questions. The Labyrinth has always overwhelmed me with its mysteries, but now things are ultimately making sense. Puzzle pieces are falling into place. I don't have all the answers yet, but I will soon.

And once I do, this insect will suffer a slow, torturous death.

He stumbles backward and glares red-hot fire at me, before turning around to give me an eyeful of his frontside that I'd rather not see. "God-dammit! Whatsh your fukin' problem! It'sh my turn today!" He blinks his eyes and wobbles unsteadily before grabbing a metal container of some sort and chugging a mouthful of liquid, which I automatically assume is alcohol. I'm suddenly extremely glad I returned my olfactory receptors to their normal levels because his odor is awful even from two dozen feet away... not to mention the stench of death in the air.

He steadies himself against a wall and squints as he stares at me. After several long seconds, he opens his eyes wide. "W-what? Soopreme Commander?! You weren't- I thought you didn't-" He spits out several words incoherently before appearing to realize something important. "Ohhh... sho *that'sh* why you protect them... sho even you have shome shecrets, eh? Eh?"

I have no idea what this moron is talking about. Slowly, I lick my lips and force myself to keep my calm. Did he call me a Supreme Commander? Why? What does that even mean? Whoever he's mistaken me for, they seem to be a military commander of some sort.

"Yes. I do. Let's just say I recently started coming here. First day. Explain to me, how... *this* works."

The idiot nods rapidly like a blubbering dog. "Oh yesh! Yesh! I knew it had ta' be you! You shaved 'n everything! You look like a younger man, really took a few yearsh off!" He stumbles forward and smiles jovially, completely clueless to the fact that his death is quite imminent. "This place ish GREAT! You can do anything you want to 'em, and they can't talk back! Way better than that wife of yoursh! Yama don't care 'bout nothin', no lawsh or anything!"

"Oh. So Yama set this up. Those girls are dead, you know."

He completely misses my tone of voice, even as he stumbles across the room and slaps his hand on my chest. "Damn shstraight! Demons eat the dead ones, so I get to do anything I want! They're just cows anyway, easy to make 'em do all sorts of sick shit!"

I've finally had enough. I can't take another second. The ugly bastard defiled these women, like some kind of animal, then he killed them. All this and Yama sanctions it? I raise my hand

up to grab him by the neck, but suddenly he pulls back and opens his eyes. "Oooh! There'sh another one right there! Lora, you're one of my favoritesh! Where you been hidin' honey? Melia and Sadie wouldn't talk, sho I made 'em shqueal like pigsh!"

I quickly turn back and spot Lora standing behind me. Somehow, despite all that clunky armor and my enhanced vision, I was so focused on the man in front of me that I missed her return. Her breathing is labored, and her eyes are open wide. Terror is evident on her face, especially as the man leers at her.

"C'mon honey, come ta' papa! I gotta find Silvia after this!" He nudges me in the chest and winks at me. "She'sh the little one. Sho shkittish, jusht the way I like 'em, heh heh."

My mind flashes back to the 12-year-old girl. This man... even with the child...

"I think you've mistaken me for someone else. I'm not your Supreme Commander." I reach forward in an instant and grab the man by his throat, glaring deep into his soul. His eyes bolt open as a sudden realization dawns on him. "I'm not the person you thought I was, but thank you for the information. Today, I will be your worst nightmare."

"L-leggo! Lemme g-oh!" He squirms in my grasp, and I start to *squeeze*. I'll choke the fucking life out of him, just like he throttled the life from-

A sudden movement.

I blink as my world turns into a blur. My hand opens almost reflexively as I fly backward, smashing into a wall behind me with incredible force. A terrible high-pitched scream fills the corridor, and I whip my head up just in time to spot Lora leaping at him. A moment later, a shockwave blasts out of the room as she pounds him against a wall, nearly destroying the wall in the process. A war cry erupts from her belly, as she jams her hand inside his chest and then rips out his spine in one motion.

The brutal murder is punctuated by an animalistic fury as she howls and cries, tearing the rapist apart, piece by piece. An arm flies to the side, his collarbone follows, other chunks I can't even identify, and soon the entire room is covered in blood. The man from before is gone. In his place are vaguely human chunks of meat and bone, spattered against the walls and across the floors.

After several seconds of panting, Lora falls to her knees and grabs the body of her friend on the floor, clutching her bruised and battered body tightly.

I carefully pull myself up and turn back to stare in awe at the wall behind me. The black tiles are shredded, and a hole the size of a small car is visible. Through the hole, I can see more slave girls staring at me with a mixture of fear, awe, and confusion. Lora must have hurled me

backward to attack the man who killed her friends. She was so afraid of him before when we were walking down the hallways, and yet she either realized he was nothing to be feared, or my training unlocked something deep in her soul.

The will to fight back.

I dust myself off and walk forward, scowling at the room where the predator had his way. Quickly, I walk over and open the chains holding the girl on the bed, then I create a blanket with wordsmithing and wrap her in it, setting her on the bed carefully. After this, I kneel down to Lora and embrace her. "You did well. He deserved to die."

My words are of little comfort as she weeps into the body of her friend. I don't know whether this one is Melia or Sadie, but either way... it was no way to go.

I bite my lip and glance back at the doorway and the corridor outside. Yama created this place. These aren't just servants to attend to his needs... he's human trafficking here. This is wrong on a level far past what it was before. I don't know the exact situation, but if this man is a human in the human military, the trafficking must be something sanctioned by the government. Hell, the man told me this place had no laws, so maybe the higher ups don't even know.

Something smells rotten, and it isn't just the death in the air and the foulness of blood and iron.

I rub Lora slowly on her back to comfort her, and I sense a movement outside the doorway. Yama appears silently, the shadowy bastard.

"What have you done?" He stares at the carnage coldly, as if it doesn't matter in the slightest.

"I put a dog down, Yama. He was a cruel deranged monster. I should be asking *you* what's going on here."

I decide not to mention it was Lora who killed him. If Yama knows the truth, he gives no indication of knowing. Instead, he hisses at me. "Fool. Going to such lengths over mere chattel... That man was Danis Thornum. He was a prestigious military general among humanity's forces. It took decades of coaxing to get him firmly on our side, and now you've undone all my hard work. He was a crucial voter in the pro-demon coalition. His voice held real sway."

"Yeah? Well, I say he was a foul monster." I stand up and walk over to Yama, staring down at the four-foot high demon, even as I glare hot coals at him. "No matter how little you care about humans, this is going too far. Humans would never do such things to your kind. We have laws. Rules."

Yama tilts his head up and surprises me by tittering to himself. It's a deep, ominous chuckle, one that hasn't a hint of joy in it. "Kukuku... how little you know, Jason Hiro. Demons number

in the tens of thousands in the labyrinth, but billions of my kind are being subjected to torture and slavery in human work camps. Even I haven't a prayer of rescuing a single one of them, due to the efficiency of human weaponry. Think with your brain, human! Do you think I do this joyfully? I do this because I must. It is one tool of many to prevent the humans from crushing my kind."

He lowers his head to stare at Lora. "She is covered in blood, and you are not. Am I really to believe that you killed Danis?"

I step in the way of his gaze. "Leave her out of this. She's my slave."

"Your slave killed an esteemed guest. I offer protection to those who come here. It's a binding contract... a blood contract. How do you wish for me to explain my failure when Danis shows up missing?"

I turn back to the room thoughtfully. "He's gone. No getting around that."

After several long seconds, an idea comes to mind. "If I can solve this... dilemma, will you promise not to take vengeance against Lora? She did what any caring human would do."

Yama takes a step back and evaluates me carefully. "Fine. I can't wait to see you get out of trouble this time."

I smile at him. "Don't underestimate a wordsmith." A moment later, I speak again. " **Clone.** "

In front of me, a clone of Danis appears and stares ahead blankly. He looks precisely as I remember he did before he died, but the clone seems almost... soulless.

A strange feeling comes over me. It's almost a sense of déjà vu. I feel as if I've done this before. It all seems so familiar...

I turn to the man. "You will vote in favor of the demons, forever, and you will never again return to this place. Continue living out your life as you were before. Do I make myself clear?"

Danis nods slowly, but it takes several seconds for him to respond. "Uh huh."

Yama's pure black eyes widen. "I see. I did not know such a power existed. Truly, this is... unprecedented."

I continue speaking to Danis. "Go back where you came. Leave this place. Never return."

The clone slowly walks away, meandering down the hallways toward an unknown destination. Yama smiles wickedly at me. "That is most convenient. Now I will not have to service his murderous escapades. He even remembers where the exit is."

"The exit?"

"Yes. There is a demon here who controls the passage of humans and demons, to-and-from this place. Grylls is his name. He is unpleasant, but he does what he must. Otherwise, the only way to leave is if you have the ability to teleport, yourself."

"I see. Is that it, then?"

Yama's smile fades, and he gazes back into the room. "That will do. I hope we have come to an understanding. As for those two, I will send in the chattel to gather them up and deliver them to the kitchen."

It takes me a few seconds, but I take a step back and scowl. "You're going to eat them?! What is wrong with you? No, I will give them a proper burial."

Yama rolls his eyes around. "Humans. *So* sentimental. It is a waste to let perfectly good flesh and energy rot in the dirt. Demons gain power from the bodies of humans, as well as other creatures. Human meat is also a delicacy among certain members of my species."

I hear a shifting behind me and turn to see Lora staring at Yama in horror.

"Well, not these two. They are Lora's friends. I won't allow it."

The shadow demon groans and turns away, tossing his hands in the air. "Fine! Do as you please! Kill my guests and take my feast! Whatever satisfies you!"

He storms away and I stare at his backside. "You really need me, don't you? Without me, you won't survive. Why else would you crumble so promptly?"

Whether he doesn't hear me or he ignores me, I don't know. He continues walking, and soon he vanishes into the shadows beyond.

This is so wrong. What hell is this place? What monster forces innocents with no ability to fight back into the jaws of their oppressors? Humanity once stood for the good of all. When I was young, the motto of my country was peace and prosperity for all. Life, liberty, and the pursuit of happiness. Did those ideals die? Do humans no longer care about the fate of one another?

Or perhaps they simply ignore this place. Maybe they don't know of its existence, or they pretend not to and call it a necessary evil. Even back before I entered the cryopod, those places existed. We called them 'black sites' and ignored the wailing of those trapped within. Who cared if a few innocents suffered, so long as the majority lived opulent lives?

I turn back to Lora. "Come on. Let's give them a proper resting place. They deserved better."

Even as I walk over and wrap the girl on the floor in a blanket, another appears in the doorway. A young girl, the one who lived here before. Lora's last remaining companion. Her

eyes are hardened, and no tears roll down her face. Already, she is used to the horrors of this place.

I nudge Lora, and when she spots her friend, she quickly stands up and dashes over to hug her.

Silvia is her name, assuming that Danis guy was right. If we leave her here, she will end up like these two. I can't have that. If I had paid more attention, their deaths could have been prevented. It's not that I cared about the lives of these women I never knew, but somehow... it feels as if I personally failed them.

But out of this, Lora gained something. The ability to stand up for herself. Even to raise her hand to me and be selfish, just this once.

I levitate both corpses onto a double-stacked gurney and cover them up out of respect for the dead. Then, I begin pushing them back down the hall towards our training area.

"I'm going to bury them where you can remember them every day, Lora. Never forget the rage you felt towards that man. You should feel that hatred towards anyone who threatens you. Understand?"

She nods slowly.

"Good. As for your friend, I will make her my slave too. I'm sure Yama will be unhappy, but it seems he has no choice except to allow me free reign. You and I will protect her."

A funny thought comes to my mind, and I smile to myself. "You know, I always wanted a daughter."

I push the gurney down the hall, and both girls follow behind me.

* * *

Sarah smiles sweetly at me on my holopad. Her face appears in the air before me in full detail, as if I was talking directly to her. "I've made all the arrangements, Jason. We'll be *fine*, so calm down!"

"Yeah, I know. You're a big girl." I smile sheepishly and scratch at my thick beard. "Tell Timothy that I expect straight A's while I'm gone. A-pluses, even. The son of a Supreme Commander can't slack off. He might have to take the reins someday."

My wife's smile wilts and she glares at me playfully. "Oh, you. It's truly something that an immortal is worried about the future. You're such a tease!"

"Yeah. A tease." I echo her words as I glance around the hangar. My spaceship is nearly prepped and loaded, and it has all sorts of amenities that will make the trip quite cushy, even if I

can just make everything I need as I go along. Magic is useful like that. "Anyway, I gotta go, sweetheart. Don't cheat on me while I'm gone."

She scoffs at me. "Jason! You jerk!"

"Kidding. Love you." I make a kissy face at the screen and shut it off afterward. I hate long goodbyes, but she's the opposite. She'll draw every farewell out into a three-week ordeal if I let her.

I sling my Mark III Anti-Energy Dematerializer over my shoulder and walk toward my ship. The hangar is colossal, easily two thousand feet tall and fifty thousand wide. Hundreds, even thousands of ships of varying sizes are lined up meticulously, from here to there, and the lower levels are even bigger, stocking several dozens of the massive freighters and carriers. Naturally, there hasn't been a need for them since the insurgencies a few millennia ago, but it never hurts to be prepared.

"Commander Hiro!" A man runs up to me and salutes, his black, undecorated uniform indicating he's one of the maintenance crewmen. "The Mothership is refueled. There was a problem with several of the replicators aboard, but if you're willing to wait, we'll have them fixed in an hour or so."

"Don't worry about it. My wife packed me a nice lunch, and I'll only be gone a few days. Prep the ship for launch."

He nods at me and scurries away briskly. I meander after him, heading in the same direction, but there's no rush. Marie is the head of the military until I get back, and while that always ruffles a few feathers, nobody dares question her competency, so there are rarely any problems. Hell, a few times she outdid me as Auxiliary Supreme Commander and made me look inferior, to the point that I asked her to take over for good. Sadly, she's too lazy and only cares about science.

Even if I were gone a year or two, the place would probably be in better condition when I got back than when I left it.

A ship docks near me and I stare up at it. It's a military vessel, small, perhaps able to crew four or five people. Not like my ship, which is comically oversized for what I need. My craft is big enough to fit thousands of people inside, but the damn thing runs mostly on autopilot, begging the question of why I need something so massive.

Dunno. Marie insisted I have a ship worthy of a Supreme Commander, so I let her build it. She has some strange nitpicks on occasion.

But, compared to this tiny vessel, my ship is a mammoth. The smaller ship has a name laser-etched on the side, 'The Dragon's Dogma.'

A fancy title, to be sure, but it seems a little pompous and arrogant. If I were an asshole, I'd order it be renamed 'The Stinger,' or something more appropriate for its size.

I continue to wait for the maintenance crew to give me the okay, and as I do, the smaller vessel lowers its landing platform and the inside opens up. A single man exits, and immediately I moan to myself and turn away, trying to make myself invisible. Maybe I should use my wordsmithing. It's that fucking Danis guy. Gods, I can't stand the brown-noser.

I listen intently, but instead of walking over to me, he sounds as if he's walking away. Only a hundred feet separate us, and surely he saw me...

I carefully look back, just in time to see him walk right past me as if I don't even exist. I must have been mistaken about where he was headed. For some reason, when he ignores me, I feel very irritated.

"Danis! Are you not going to salute your commander?"

He continues walking for a second or two before slowly coming to a stop and turning back to me. "Oh. Hello, Supreme Commander. I did not expect to run into you a second time."

His words come out oddly, almost mechanically, as if he's forcing himself to talk. Compared to the normal, slimy way he slides the words out, he is much creepier than before.

"A second time? Are you feeling all right, Admiral? You look a little pale."

"Yes, Supreme Commander. Thank you for your concern. I am fine."

He turns back around slowly and continues walking.

How... odd. I've known the man for way too long and he's never acted like that before. Maybe he's tired or something. Admittedly, I've never chatted with him in an informal setting, but still...

Ah, whatever. It's none of my concern. I ought to just be glad he doesn't feel the need to speak with me. This is a blessing! Cheer up, me!

The crew from my ship beckon for me to come over, and I briskly make my way there, but even as I do, I glance at Danis's back as he walks away.

Something sure was strange about him today.

Part 395b: Repression

" **Bury.** "

With a single word, the ground in the training room heaves up and engulfs the bodies of the two girls, pulling them down into a permanent resting place. Lora wipes away a tear, but Silvia stares stonily. Silvia, I've noticed in the short time since I met her, never emotes in the slightest. She helped me move their bodies down, since I felt using telekinesis would have a less somber feeling to it, and she never once appeared sad or cried.

I haven't either, of course. I don't care about the dead girls. I never knew them, and their only meaning to me was that of how they made Lora feel. She was close friends with both of them, and even as we watch the bodies get swallowed into the blackened dirt, she rests an arm on the younger girl's shoulder. She cares about Silvia, that I can tell, but Silvia doesn't seem to return those feelings.

I don't know what to make of the situation. Perhaps we should leave Silvia to the labyrinth and let her continue living her life, but on the other hand, she would be useful to me, possibly in some small way. She might help motivate Lora with a motherly instinct, guiding Lora to improve herself to protect the young girl.

Then again, the cold, emotionless eyes I've spotted in Silvia have their uses. In time... she might grow to outperform even her senior.

I glower at the newly erected graves as the ground finishes shifting around. It occurred to me afterward that instead of just sending Danis off to return to the human realm, I could have taken some of his memories. Those might have been quite valuable and given me real insight into the state of the galaxy. I am still coming up short on too many details for my liking, and this revelation about memory theft came to me from nowhere, like a faint whisper from the past.

Sometimes I feel as if I'm on the cusp of remembering a past life, something involving reincarnation. It's stupid, of course, but it still itches at the back of my mind. I find it hard to explain with words, but it is pervasive, never leaving me.

Sometimes the subconscious self can be a buffoon.

"Silvia. I'm going to pull you from Yama, and you will be my slave, along with Lora. As such, I am giving you back that which was taken from you." Silvia looks up at me questioningly, and Lora turns to me in surprise, even while I speak again. " **Heal. Regenerate.** "

For the next minute, Silvia finally opens her eyes in shock and staggers backward, grasping at her mouth and throat as her vocal cords and tongue return from the nether.

Several minutes pass, and she sits on the ground breathing quietly. Then she surprises me by speaking. "You heal me. Why?"

It takes me a moment to realize she can talk, but I gather my wits about me. "I will do this for all slaves I take from Yama. He has his way, and I have mine."

"Oh." She doesn't thank me, though I ponder to myself that might be due to her upbringing. "What you want me do?"

I stare at the young girl, with her short-cropped black hair and eyes of a similar shade, and ponder the question to myself. What do I want?

Well, she has to learn to protect herself, just as Lora did. That is non-negotiable. But her small size means I should probably train her differently from Lora. Besides, if we were in a video game, it would be stupid to have a party of only warriors.

Silvia and I stare at each other silently as I think and she waits patiently. Finally, I have my answer. "I will train you to be an assassin."

"Okay." She doesn't question me, but instead just nods. Good. I like that. At least subservient slaves don't give me lip, which works out better for both of us.

" **Knife. Knife. Knife.** " I create three knives, all of them with double sided blades that taper into elegant triangle points, and small handles suited for her hands. Then I give them to her. "I know your friends died, but a demon will not wait for your sadness to end. You have to start training immediately."

"I not sad. Them not important." She stands up and takes the knives away from me, staring at them questioningly. "What do with these?"

I point her at a training dummy Lora broke yesterday. "I want you to practice throwing these knives. It will take a lot of work, but eventually, you should be able to stab that dummy from this distance right on that red dot in the center of its chest. Do you see it?"

She barely even nods. "Yes. Will try."

Do or do not, there is no try. I feel the urge to say those words but shake my head instead. I'm not that wise, so it's best I don't pretend otherwise.

"Uh, get a bit closer though. While you're first starting, you're going to miss a lot, and your arms are probably too weak to throw them a hundred feet." I quickly aim my mind at a spot twenty feet from the dummy and use my telekinesis to etch an X into the ground. "Stand and throw from there."

Silvia obediently walks away as soon as I'm done talking, and I hastily speak up to remind her of one thing. "Also, if you get hurt, stab yourself, or cut off a finger or something, tell me at once. I can heal any wound, but I can't bring back the dead."

She doesn't nod or say anything, but a quick mental impression I get from her tells me she heard.

Hmm, come to think of it... how do I know I can't bring back the dead? I've never even tried. Maybe my power is more mysterious than I thought.

Oh well. I turn back to Lora and sigh silently to myself. She's still staring emptily at the place where her friends are buried. I take a few steps towards her and rub her arms. "I'm sorry about what happened. Nobody deserves to go out like that. However, you avenged them. You did the right thing."

She bobs her head and another tear comes trickling down. Strange, I always thought of Lora as not caring much about the other slaves, but perhaps I don't understand her as well as I thought I did.

"All right. Come on, let's get back to training. No matter how long you stare, you can't bring them back. The best way to honor their memory is to become powerful so you can punish filth like Danis whenever you encounter them."

When I speak his name, a shudder runs down her spine and she pulls away from me, pushing past to head over to the training dummy I made yesterday. I ignore the slight, as it would be discourteous of me to call out someone grieving. Still, she has to get over them eventually. One cannot dwell on the past forever, or it will damage their future.

I grimace as I spot large chunks of flesh and blood covering the backside of her armor. Her plate mail is filthy now and coated in that man's blood. "**Clean.**" It vanishes and I breathe a sigh of relief, wondering to myself why I suddenly felt so possessive. Well, there's nothing wrong with that. I saved her, so she's mine. It's that simple.

Danis didn't just kill the two girls I buried; he had apparently hurt Lora and Silvia in the past too. That explains the marks on Lora's back. I had thought the demons did that to her, but thinking of the human and how he treated members of his own species, it occurs to me that perhaps there are monsters on both sides of the conflict.

I need to know more. I need to find out the full situation.

"Oohh!" Silvia lets out a yelp, and I quickly turn to look at her, wondering what happened. I'm mildly amused to see that she's already planted a knife square in the center of the dummy's chest.

"Excellent. Now you just need to get to a point where you can do that fifty times in a row without missing, and we'll move onto bigger things."

Silvia's expression of awe at her skills dissolves instantly as I suck the wind out of her sails. She slumps down a little and goes back to throwing her knives. She'll be fine. A little disappointment is good for the soul.

Lora picks up her sword and shield and starts hacking at her dummy, carefully chopping each limb off, one by one. I watch with a slight disinterest and notice she's more precise with her strikes than before. There's an intent to kill that I didn't feel yesterday. Killing Danis must have changed something about her.

I grab my sword out of the ground and walk up behind her. "Lora, enough with the dummy. This time I want you to go on the offense against me."

She stops and turns to look at me, but once again I see that same hesitation from before. She looks nervous at the thought of swinging a sword at me.

"Go on. Do it. I'm waiting." I raise my sword and assume a defensive stance, so she hesitantly assumes an offensive one, but even as she shifts around, I can already tell she isn't going to attack.

"Come on, Lora. You threw me out of the way to get at Danis. Channel that anger once again. Attack me mercilessly. I'm plenty protected, so you won't be able to do serious harm."

I think. I swallow at the thought that maybe my invisible armor isn't as sturdy as I expect.

Still, she doesn't move to attack. Her face is resolute, and it's starting to piss me off. "Lora, this is childish. I don't care what your feelings are towards me, you have to treat me like you did-" I pause as an idea crosses my mind. It only takes a second, and I quickly put it into action. "**Disguise.**"

I feel my body shift as my features change. I don't have a mirror to see myself, but the sudden change in Lora's expression as her face melts into an expression of horror is enough to make me giddy. Finally, she knows I'm serious. I start to speak, and already my voice sounds just like Danis's did. "Come on, bitch. If you don't take a swing at me, I'll kill that little girl. Yeah, that's right! I'll kill Silvia! What are you going to do now, eh? I'll fucking cut her into little pieces and feed her to the dogs! Bet you'd like that, wouldn't you?"

Silvia hears my altered voice and turns around to gawk in amazement, or perhaps disgust. I can't be sure, but based on the look they're giving me, I must look just like the filthy animal.

"Come on! DO IT! If you don't, I'll kill the little girl! I'm not bluffing either, you worthless whore!"

I perceive the exact moment Lora snaps. She can't take the taunting anymore, or my face resembling Danis's. Lora leaps at me with a ferocity far overwhelming what I expected, and I rear back in surprise. Her speed increases as she slams her sword down at my head and she shoves her shield into my gut at the same time. I deflect the sword but get knocked backward by the shield.

A stab, a parry, we trade blows and I keep getting forced back, all while she howls something inhuman, the sounds that escape her mouth sounding even more primal than what she let out against Danis just a while earlier. Truth be told, I can't hold off against her, and have to keep increasing my strength just to parry. Her berserker rage just becomes even worse when she feels me resisting more.

"All right, that's enough! You did a good job-" I'm cut off as she bashes me in the face with an elbow and knocks me on my ass. It doesn't hurt, but I roll out of the way just as her sword smashes into the ground where I was sitting, blasting dirt up into the air from under the black tiles that cover the floor.

She isn't listening to me and instead is releasing the anger she's been holding in ever since she saw me let Danis walk away. Maybe she doesn't know why I let him go, but she still resents me for it. Even so, this is getting dangerous. I have to get her to stop.

I lift my head up just in time to see a boot swing at my face. A moment later my world goes spinning end over end as she kicks me thirty feet back, smashing me against a wall. My mind is swirling, and I shake the feeling away, before aiming a word at myself. "**Normalize.**"

My body shifts once again, and I breathe quickly as I wonder if I look like myself again. Lora, however, doesn't seem to care that I look like myself, and she jumps at me and swings again, though I dodge the attack and slip around behind her with surprising agility. Using little effort, I send a telekinetic wave into her backside, smashing her against the wall where she just pummeled me.

Finally, this seems to knock some sense into her, and she steps away from the wall, turning to look at me. Her nose is broken, and tears are pouring down her face.

"Christ's sake! I told you to calm down!" I jam my sword in the ground and walk over to her, cupping her chin in my hand. "Let me have a look. That's a nasty break."

She nods slightly, and her anger fades away in an instant. I heal her nose, and both of us stare at each other for several long seconds.

"Are you feeling better now? Did you get that rage out of your system?"

Lora shifts her shoulders and averts her eyes, and then she does something completely shocking. She jumps at me and wraps her arms around me, pressing us close together.

I return the embrace, and she slowly looks up into my eyes. A question is visible, deep inside her mind. I softly probe with my telepathy before smiling at her. "Yes, you may."

We kiss, and I press her face against mine. My hand glides along the back of her head, subtly making her move how I want her to.

Seconds pass, and finally, we pull our lips apart. Lora's breathing is shallow, and she says nothing, but I can tell by the few days we've been together what she's thinking at a glance.

A hint of motion to my left makes me glance over at Silvia. She's watching us with a silent stare. There's no curiosity, or interest, or envy, or anything else. She's just... watching.

I pull myself away from Lora and both of us suddenly feel the awkwardness in the air. Silvia isn't making things any easier.

Lora rubs her knees together and smiles shyly, so I turn to Silvia. "Let's call it a day. That's enough training for now. We'll go back to my room and I'll carve you out an alcove across the hallway."

She just nods. "Okay."

* * *

I beam down from my ship into the main labyrinth entry facility. Instantly, all the personnel on deck stop and salute me, probably by the order of a yet unseen person. "As you were." I nod at them and continue walking forwards towards the gate that will warp me into the Labyrinth. It's a massive circular thing, big enough to fit an enormous tank from my youth. That is, one of those primitive vehicles that moved on treads. They fired rather weak metal shells with an explosive compound, as I recall.

The hangar is decent sized, though nothing like Earth's main military port. A handful of starships of varying sizes are lined up beside mine, with space for at least ten more on this level. Dozens of men and women roam about, here and there, dressed in different colored uniforms, such as orange, green, and black. My eyes look past them all and stare silently at the gate that Marie Becker helped design. Unlike what the angels and demons use to get from their dimensions to ours, our warp gate is powered by normal energy, and a colossal amount of it. This star system alone needed to build a Dyson Sphere just to give the gate the power that it needed.

As I head towards the warp gate, a plain looking woman walks up to me. "Supreme Commander, I'm Sergeant Florence. I'm in charge of this facility. We weren't expecting you."

Her tan hair is chopped back in a masculine style, a butch cut that doesn't make her look as gentle as she could otherwise. I do prefer long hair on a woman.

"Yes, I remember you. I believe you helped during the Era of Suppression. You led the all-female Verus Battalion, as a matter of fact. How have you been?"

She blushes. "I'm surprised you remember that, Supreme Commander. That was such a long time ago. I didn't even do all that much. It took a concerted effort during those dark times."

"Of course. However, some people exerted more effort than others. You lead the defense force to protect this gate, so that makes you rather important in case the demons get uppity. A fitting promotion, I'd say."

"Yeah. It's a shame immortals don't get to retire permanently."

"You're telling me." I rub my forehead and grunt a little bit. "I've got a splitting headache. Anyway, I'm heading into the labyrinth."

Her eyes open wide in surprise. "You are? I beg your pardon, Commander, but surely whatever the reason is, you could send someone else in. Humanity can't afford to lose the highest ranking leader we've got. At the least, I'll pull together an elite guard for you."

I shake my head and smile. "That won't be necessary. This is a... diplomatic mission. Yes, I need to go in by myself. You know how weak the demons have become."

She bobs her head slowly. "I... see. Extending an olive branch then, are you? A noble gesture, but if the demons capture you, it's all over. I can't let you go in alone, even if you are the Supreme Commander. Humanity's fate rests in your hands."

I lick my lips slowly. "I'm just one man, Florence. I can be replaced. That being said, I think you are underestimating me... and overstepping your authority. I outrank you in every meaning of the word. Activate the gate, and step aside."

"I... I can't just do that, Supreme Commander. You know what you're asking of me, right?"

"I do." I reach up and scratch my grizzled beard thoughtfully. "Truth be told, I don't have to use this gate. I could just use another route, but it would waste my... *energy*, and leave me weakened. Is that what you would prefer?"

She looks back and forth at a few passing crewman, but they offer her no easy answers. "Well, no..."

"So step aside." I lean down close and murmur so only she can hear. "You have distinguished yourself over the years, but there's no reason I can't strip you of your rank and put in someone more loyal. You know what happens to traitors, don't you?"

Her glee at seeing me from earlier is completely gone. She takes a hesitant step backward. "Not the mines... you wouldn't..."

"This mission is imperative to the survival of humanity. Activate the gate, *Sergeant*. I'm not asking again."

Finally, defeat is visible in her eyes. "Alright... fine. I'll do it. Just... be careful, Commander. There are still unpredictable and savage demons in the labyrinth."

"I'm counting on it." My hypersuit seals up and my faceplate closes as she inputs a long series of digits into the password matrix. When the gate begins to activate, a hundred soldiers line up, weapons at the ready, just in case anything should exit through the gate.

"Thank you, Sergeant. I remember those who are friends."

Walking forward, I step through the warp gate as it opens up, stepping into a place I haven't been in millions of years.

The soldiers on the other side are much tenser and more alert than the ones on humanity's side. They barely nod at me, waiting until the instant I walk through to close the gate down.

A man speaks up. "Just one? You're joking."

I shake my head and walk past him, smiling to myself. He can't see my face, and this suit is a nondescript model, so he has no way of knowing who I am. "Special orders. I'll be out in a day or two."

"It's your grave, buddy." The soldier's voice sounds off after me as I trudge down a long, dark hallway, leading deep into the labyrinth of Hell.

There's another Wordsmith in here, skulking about in the shadows. I need to find and capture them. I just pray I'm not too late... the potential for casualties is too high.

Part 396b: Pawn

Silvia and Lora trudge along the hallway in front of me. We're supposed to find and take out a rogue commando who's been attacking and capturing demons in the Labyrinth for the last couple weeks. Yama seems to think this one is more troublesome than a few others, but he also appeared to care about other things that were more pressing to him. He spends a lot of time inside of the room with the crystallized girl, I've noticed.

Lora and Silvia walk a few paces ahead of me, occasionally making hand motions toward each other, almost like sign language. I've noticed that despite being able to speak, Silvia only ever does so when I talk to her and otherwise doesn't appear to have any interest in doing so unless prompted. With Lora, she always prefers letting her hands do the talking.

As well, I've given Silvia her new outfit befitting her 'class'. With the ability to turn invisible and teleport a few dozen feet in any direction, it seems she's something of an assassin, trained to take down an enemy in a single blow. Her shadow-colored shirt and pants match the black tone of her cloak that she keeps wrapped around her at all times.

Lora, on the other hand, wears pure white armor, made of plate-mail and reinforced beyond the limits of ordinary steel. I'm confident that with her enhanced strength and durability, a tank blasting her at point blank range would merely knock the wind out of her. The white armor serves not just as a contrast to Silvia's, but it also allows Lora to draw an enemy's attention. This, in turn, should allow Silvia to strike from the shadows.

Heh... and myself, of course. I don't know who this Golden Commando is, but I've got something I've been working on. Just a theory though.

Reflexively, my hand reaches down and grasps the heavy pouch at my side. I exhale a sigh of relief as I feel the dense pebbles rolling around inside, safe and secure. Creating new ones is easily possible, but keeping my most powerful weapon at hand will save me the trouble in the heat of a battle.

Lora turns her head back to look at me, having heard me sigh. I pull my mouth taut, in a half-smile. "It's nothing. Keep walking."

She nods silently and goes back to emoting at Silvia with her hands. I glance at a three-dimensional map floating in the air before me. The girls can't see it, as it's only visible to myself. Using the word spell "map", it turned out I could create a partial map of the nearby Labyrinth. Roughly ten miles in any direction, and what I can see is... astonishing.

Yama told me before about the Labyrinth. The scale is unimaginable, far bigger than Earth if it were hollow, and even sphere-like. The Labyrinth expands outward slowly, draining the essence of its denizens a trickle at a time. The Labyrinth's growth has decayed exponentially over its lifetime, starting rapidly in the early years, and slowing down over time, particularly since the demons were killed off in the past. With so few demons in the maze now, and it being thousands and thousands of miles in diameter, there is a definite limit to its edges.

I wonder what I would discover if I walked to the ends of the Labyrinth? That's a question for another day.

Silvia and Lora pause ahead of me as the dull walls of this place start slowly expanding out and the ceiling raises up. I glance at my map and raise an eyebrow. "The walls shifted again. It's almost like this place is a living, breathing entity. I feel as though this maze is taking us somewhere, to some destination."

"Yes. Walls open, walls close. Maze doesn't like humans."

Silvia offers some helpful commentary, and I glance at her from the corner of my eye. Lora can't speak or doesn't want to, so I never get information about her past. After the first time I probed her mind, I haven't wanted to go back in. Unlike Lora though, Silvia *can* speak, but she chooses to evade any questions I ask her.

It's frustrating, but given time I suspect she will open up to me. She, like Lora, has discovered the joys of pizza and soda, so I think she'll tell me about her past once the time is right.

"Yeah, you said it. I don't like humans either." I make some small talk and we press forward into the ever expanding area ahead. I'm surprised to see the moss from before when I first encountered the human commandos a few weeks ago. It appears sparsely at first, coating the floor around us, and eventually becomes thicker until the point I can't see the Labyrinth's dirt surface anymore.

I feel a sense of unease in my gut, before finally pausing. "You two go on ahead. I'll stay behind and follow, invisibly. If you see any humans wearing white armor, attack them. I will finish them off."

Both girls look at each other, shrug, and then turn back to nod at me. Then they take off walking again, both of them unsheathing their weapons... just in case.

" Invisible. Reptile. "

My body immediately begins to cool, and I feel a stiff breeze blowing around in this area that I didn't feel before. Being cold blooded means I'm much more acutely aware of the temperature

in the room, and only now do I realize this place is rather damp and cold. It makes sense, given these are the sorts of conditions that would lead to moss growing everywhere.

The room is very dark, unlike the other time I encountered moss in a wide-open area. No darker than the rest of the Labyrinth, but due to its sheer size, the feeling is more ominous.

" Vision. "

I boost my visual acuity and quickly look in all directions. In the center of the room is, strangely, a large tree. A Weeping Willow, if I had to guess, though I'm no expert in botany. The long, thick branches, of which there are hundreds, indicate this tree is ancient. I remember reading when I was younger that there were trees known to be thousands of years or older, but this tree probably dwarfs even those. Its branches expand out hundreds of feet, and it has two trunks buried in the ground, with the second likely having grown out over time to support the weight of its branches. Much of the tree sags under the bulk of its leaves, and the feeling the tree gives off is something akin to a creepy longing for freedom.

How a tree could survive in darkness like this is a mystery to me, but my questions will go unanswered. The next things I spot are large pods, egg-like in nature, resembling something an animal would escape from. All of them are cracked and old, and already opened up from the top. Whatever things they once held, those creatures have long since left.

I rub my arms to try and warm them up, but the chill in this room isn't entirely due to the temperature. It has the smell of death in the air.

Up ahead, Lora and Silvia walk forward, with Lora holding her torch up high to scan for enemies. I'm just about to call them back and shake my feelings off as merely nerves, when a voice speaks out, masculine, brimming with age, and slightly robotic, possibly due to a voice filter.

"I knew you were coming here. I've been waiting days for someone to show up. Though... you are not what I expected."

A white suited commando falls from a spot up in the tree where the leaf cover had shielded him, and lands on the ground somewhat quietly. "A disguise, is it? Which of you is the Wordsmith?"

So he knows I'm a Wordsmith, huh?

I send a mental command to both girls at once. "Attack him now. I'll intervene when the time is right."

No hesitation. Both girls use the killer instinct I've been cultivating in them and charge at the man, ignoring his probing to try and finish him in one blow.

They will fail, of course... but it's what I will learn in the meantime that will be most useful to me.

Lora leaps at him and swings her sword down. He bats it away with his armored hand and punches her, but her armor protects her completely. Meanwhile, Silvia activates her invisibility and teleports behind him, using her enhanced strength to batter him from behind.

The man stumbles forward, not having expected the attack, before lunging his arm to grab at Silvia wildly. He misses, thanks to her ridiculous speed, and she pounds him again from the sides.

One fact begins to set in, as the three combatants trade blows... this man doesn't seem to be adept at fighting. I might be wrong, however.

I teleport up to the ceiling, silently, and mutter under my breath. " **Adhere.** "

Carefully moving around so as not to make noise, I keep my eye on this figure.

* * *

Lora and Silvia gasp for breath while I watch from a distance. By keeping my blood cooled and my body invisible, the white-suited figure hasn't seen me yet. He's occupied by the girls and their relentless attacks on him.

Well, their attacks *were* relentless. That was fifteen minutes ago. Silvia's invisibility has worn off now as she lacks the energy to maintain it. Lora is wheezing after a torrent of attacks the commando managed to defend against with minimal effort. Who's inside that suit? There is a field of energy surrounding his suit that blocks my magic, so I can't get a bead on his identity.

Suddenly the commando swivels his head up to look directly at me. "I see you, wordsmith. I know you're up there. Stop sending these children to me, or I'll make you regret that decision."

I stiffen and shiver, as the masked face stares at me unblinkingly. I can't see the man's appearance behind that tinted plexiglass helmet, but somehow I feel as if his eyes are burning a hole in my chest.

"You're good. Those suits are no joke." I hop down and land on the ground, keeping my distance from him. It's just one commando, but with that energy nullification effect active, if he grabs me, I probably won't be able to use my magic.

"The suit is merely a precaution. I have to be careful against another wordsmith."

The hair raises on the back of my neck. "You... you're a wordsmith as well?"

A tinge of confusion enters his voice. "Of course I am. Don't you know? You set all of this up to draw me here."

I grit my teeth and scowl at him, though I suspect he can't see my invisible body or my expression. "What the hell are you talking about? I did no such thing."

His head tilts, as if he's following my voice. Carefully, I move to his side and narrow my eyes as I realize he's not tracking my movements. "Of course you did. You attacked and nearly defeated a contingent of my elite forces. Do you think I'm stupid? No demon could have done that, and then subsequently held off against them once they activated the Containment Protocol. It was designed to be unbeatable. Hell, you were even toying with them during that phase, and then you left as if none of it mattered to you."

"I don't know what you're talking about." I speak up, and his head immediately turns to look at me. As I thought, he can't see me. I'm still invisible.

I notice something else. The energy field surrounding him will occasionally turn off for a split second before resuming. Each time this happens, he tracks onto my position again. Is he using wordsmithing to follow after me when I move? Why would he need to disable the field around himself if that were the case?

The only explanation I can think of is that he can't wordsmith while the field is active. Interesting.

An ounce of irritation sprouts in his voice. "Stop trying to size me up. Come out of hiding and let me see your face."

"Me? Size you up? I don't know what you're talking about. I'm just walking around."

"Of course you are. I'm millions of years old, child. I have dealt with many enemies. You've realized I can't see you, and now you're trying to figure out why."

I shake my head, even though he won't know I did. "Wrong. I already figured it out. Being unable to track me visually or by using heat detection is bad enough, but the final layer was sonar. That was the only way I could think of that the commando suits were able to follow me around in the end. Because of that, I made myself emit my own sonic pulses to jam yours."

"Smart." The man's gruff voice growls out the word. "I'll bet you're real proud of yourself for figuring that out."

"I do what I can."

In truth, I'm a little worried. Wordsmithing has so many practical applications that I can't defend against them all. It's unreasonable to try. I already realized that if Yama weren't lying and I did have to face another Wordsmith, words like 'kill' and 'die' would be the end of me, but there are so many other terms that do the same thing. My ultimate defense will end up being my physical regeneration, and my invisible armor. It gives me an edge.

The man shrugs, finally. "I tire of this. If you will not show me your face, I'll show you mine." He snickers to himself. "Heh, though doubtless you already know my identity."

I don't get a chance to ask what he means by that. His faceplate slides up, and I feel my gut wrench.

The face staring at me is my own. Older, much older. A few scars here and there, and plenty of hair everywhere, but my face nonetheless. I quickly realize that the voice I've been hearing all along was mine, albeit piped through a robotic filter.

"You're me? How is this possible?"

My words make the smile plastered across his face melt away. "What? What are you talking about?"

" **Normalize.** " My invisibility disappears, as does my lizard-like skin. His expression changes to disbelief, mirroring my own.

"Are you disguising yourself? Is this a practical joke?"

I curl up my lip at him. "I'm not disguising myself. If anyone is, it's you. I'm Jason Hiro."

He shakes his head at me and closes up his helmet. "Wrong. I am Jason Hiro, Supreme Commander of the United Earth Forces. You are an imposter. Though for what reason you choose to mimic my appearance, I am not certain."

"What?! You're copying me, *almighty* Wordsmith!" I gnash my teeth together and shoot a look over at Lora and Silvia, sending them a mental communication. *Get back! I'll take him on myself!* "I won't have you fuckers toying with my mind! Yama was right... you put me in that pod, and I don't even remember why!"

"Pod? What are you babbling about now? Never mind. It doesn't matter. You will submit to my authority and stand trial for the assault of my Golden Commandos, or I will force you to do so. It's the easy way or the *really* easy way. Make your choice."

My anger turns into a fleeting smile. "Ah, now your true colors emerge. You were acting like such a straight-laced shooter, I almost thought you were on the good side. Are you going to kill me, then? Throw me in a prison camp, like you did to the demons?"

He jams a thumb in his chest. "I saved their lives! Those demons should be thankful I am such a lenient and forgiving commander! However, whatever scheme they've concocted by summoning you, I won't forgive them this time."

"Tough talk for a 'supreme commander.' Let's see if you're as good of a fighter as your military title implies."

He charges at me, and I activate my invisibility and cold blood once again. I dash to the side and he swings wildly at where I had been standing, missing me entirely. When I look back, I catch sight of a massive battle-staff he pulled from out of nowhere.

"You think you can hit what you can't see?!"

"I can see you, every time you open your stupid mouth!" He hurls his staff at me with a flick of his wrist, and the speed catches me off-guard, smacking me in the chest and knocking me onto my ass.

"Oops, did I hit you? I thought you were impossible to see!" His voice is frantic as if he's suddenly excited to fight. "I'll try to take it easy on a rookie like you, even if I am a little out of shape!"

I feel his defenses slip for a moment as his head whips toward me. The energy fades away for just a split second, and I take my opportunity. " **Die!** "

The energy field reappears, and he laughs. "Good one! Predictable, too!"

"I figured it wouldn't work. I just didn't want to have to use my best move yet." My words sound almost apologetic, like I'm making excuses, but I'm not.

I have a weapon. It will surely work one time, I just don't know if he will be able to defend against it after that.

Telekinetically, I yank a pebble out of the pouch at my waist and aim my mind at it, but he's gone. Did he teleport?

A yelp in the distance. I turn to follow the sound, and spot him on the opposite side of the tree, holding Silvia up by the back of her neck. His massive hand wraps around her and holds her taut, even as she struggles to break free.

"Give it up, imposter. I have your friend hostage."

I stare at him coolly, the pebble still floating in midair. "Oh. I see. What do you think that will accomplish?"

He hasn't noticed the tiny rock yet. "If you choose to keep fighting me, I will kill her."

He stares at where I'm standing, but he can't see me, or the look of incredulity on my face. "So that's how it is, then? Taking a child hostage?"

Silvia whimpers as he tightens his grip, to the point where her body goes limp from pinched nerves. Her breathing slows down as she begins to lose consciousness.

"That's right. You wouldn't let an innocent child die, would you?"

Finally, I smirk and shake my head. "Ahh... you don't know a thing about me after all, do you? Alright, then. Kill her."

Lora turns to stare at me in horror, and the man's posture shifts slightly. "What?"

"Kill her. She got caught. Worthless. I didn't waste my time training Silvia just for her to become a hostage."

He hesitates for several long seconds before chuckling. "Hehe... I see how it is. Pretending not to care, acting cool. You care more than you let on, 'Jason'."

I shake my head slowly and sigh. "No, I don't. Just kill her."

His grip slackens slightly, and I can tell he's staring at me in disbelief. "I... I can't just... kill a child."

I normalize myself and become visible once again so that I can sneer at him. "Now I see the extent of your willpower. You're looking for an easy answer, aren't you? You thought this would bend me to your will. You think she gives you power over me? Not a chance."

Neither of us says anything for a few seconds, so I shrug nonchalantly. "Fine. If you won't do it, *I will*. **Explode**."

The look of momentary panic on Silvia's face doesn't move me. She was useless, in the end. A failure. Not even as valuable as bait.

Her entire body blasts into pieces, a fountain of blood and bone surging in all directions, coating the 'supreme commander' in her essence and making him stagger back a few steps in horror.

His guard lowers, and I finally spot my opportunity. Aiming my mind at the pebble floating before me, I speak again. " **FIRE!** "

Part 397b: Railgun

For several agonizing moments, I lose my ability to think clearly. The oxygen vanishes from the room, the air screams in pain, and space begins to warp. The lone pebble blasts forward at 99% the speed of light, leaving a wake of destruction in its path. The air superheats with a force not dissimilar to a tiny nuclear weapon, and the only reason I don't instantly die is due to the ultra-strong armor surrounding me.

I blink slowly and manage to dry tears from my eyes, tears that came unbidden due to the intense heat in the room. When I pull myself up, all the moss around me is charred black. It takes a few more seconds for my eyes to stop tingling enough for me to see, but I spot Lora smashed against a wall over on the far right side of this room. She isn't dead, which I can tell since my hearing can detect her heartbeat. She isn't in good condition either though.

My pain receptors finally activate, and I wheeze, glancing down to see dozens of severe burns covering my skin. It's a miracle I'm not dead. Already, my skin is healing itself using the regeneration spell I cast on myself a few weeks ago to repair the damage. I cast another healing spell just to speed up the process, and then treat Lora as well.

Now I can look for the Supreme Commander, and figure out what is going on here. As I stand, I gaze over to where I shot the pebble. Like the others I carry with me, it was a super-hardened, ultra-dense rock, weighing over a pound despite being the size of the last bone in my pinky. Using the pebble like a railgun, the damage I was able to cause with it was far greater than anything I could have expected. Possibly too great, though I had to be sure. I couldn't take a chance on testing it inside the labyrinth since that might draw unwanted attention. I also wasn't sure if I would survive, and I nearly died anyway.

The direction I shot the pebble toward is a mess. The entire wall is gone, and a hole the size of a truck stretches for miles into the distance. Only when I look closer do I spot the body of my doppelganger, lying in a pool of his blood.

I stagger over to him and stare at his trembling body. There's a hole in his chest, about the size of my fist, but no blood is pouring from it. The rock entered his armor, blew out his chest, and erupted through the rear armor, while the intense heat cauterized the wound. Of course, his body is charred beyond belief, but I smile to myself as I spot a finger twitching.

"You... aren't dead. Good..." My mouth feels like I've been chewing iron for a week, and my throat is dry like a cockroach on an open flame, but I can at least speak a little bit. "You will... give me answers..."

His faceplate slides open, and the broken face of a proud man stares back at me. His mouth opens and closes slightly, but no words are spoken. He can't talk since his chest has a giant goddamn hole in it. It appears he has the same regenerative powers that I do, but the damage he took was catastrophic compared to myself.

My smile increases once I realize the unusual neutralization field from earlier is gone. I can read his mind now, and he appears to also be adept in telepathy, which I find out as his voice arises in my mind.

Bastard. I can't believe I lost to someone like you... I knew I was rusty but... this was beyond my worst nightmares.

I lean back and pull myself into a sitting position on the ground beside him. *You just had to come storming in here, huh? What did you think would happen? You didn't even put up a good fight.*

A single pained tear rolls down his face. *I've never seen another Wordsmith before. I didn't... I didn't know it would end like this. The demons have never been able to fight me on equal terms. It's not fair... who are you? How are you so strong?*

I told you already. I'm Jason Hiro. I awoke in a cryopod a few weeks ago. Ever since then, I've been on a mission to find out what is going on in this universe.

A... cryopod? His eyes widen slightly before he turns his eyes away from me. He stays deep in thought for a few long moments before looking back. *Humanity hasn't used cryo-freezing for millions of years... I don't understand how you came to be here.*

You don't have to understand. Just give me the answers I want. My smile fades away as I sweep my gaze over his broken body. *On second thought, you don't need to tell me anything. It would take too long, and I wouldn't know if you're lying.*

He closes his eyes. *So you're going to kill me, then? We shouldn't be enemies. We should combine our powers.*

Kill you? Not until I get the information I need from you. I don't know how you became a Supreme Commander with such pathetic combat capabilities, but it's clear you're not adept at culling the filth.

His eyes shoot open, and he glares at me. *Culling? I've never killed a soul in my life! I couldn't take someone's life unless it was absolutely necessary.*

Oh? I raise an eyebrow in surprise. *So you've never killed anyone in your entire life? That's pretty unbelievable, for a demigod with the ability to shape words into reality.*

His arm moves a smidge, and he winces in pain. *What would you know? You murdered... that poor little girl. She looked up to you. She followed your orders. How could you do such a thing?*

I have my own ideals, Other-Jason. You were willing to use her as a pawn against me, ready to scare the living hell out of her and threaten her with death. The difference is that I was willing to follow through.

I bite my lip and realize how pointless this conversation is. I'm arguing with a weaker, inferior version of myself.

Lora walks up behind me and stands silently. I turn my head to look back at her, grimacing at how her face and neck have been terribly burned. No matter, I'll get rid of those soon.

"Do you hate me, Lora? I killed Silvia, after all. You can strike me down now, while I am weak."

She nods slowly and her hand goes for her sword but pauses as she wrestles with the decision inside of herself.

"Think about it. I saved your life. I healed you, gave you everything. I did the same for Silvia, but she failed me and paid the price. Don't you think it's fair that I took back my investment? If it weren't for me, Danis would have surely killed her anyway. All I asked in return for my generosity was that she be competent."

I turn my head back to the half-dead man in front of me and shake my head. "In the end, her most useful asset was distracting him with her death."

Stop agitating her. The Supreme Commander's voice speaks in my mind. *She's in pain, bastard. You killed her friend right in front of her. Don't you care about the feelings of others?*

I wheeze out a dry chuckle. *Not in the slightest. Lora's just a tool for my own use.*

His mental voice shakes in my mind. *You're... not human. No man I know would speak like that, think like that.*

I pause to consider my own thoughts on the matter. When did I start reasoning like this? Was it before I entered the cryopod? I was always a good-natured person before. Did something change me inside that icy coffin?

A faint whisper appears in my mind, reminding me of a battle I once fought. Well, it's more like a hallucination, since such a thing never happened, but it does make me feel very melancholic.

There's a shifting of movement to my side. I look up to see Lora, with her sword held up in a tentative fighting stance. Her knees are shaking, and her lip quivers as she digests the thought

of attacking me.

"Are you going to do it? Don't keep me waiting. You're either loyal or you're strong. Weak, or a traitor. There's no easy answer here, Lora. Either show respect to the one who saved your life, or honor the memory of a girl you once shared a room with. What will it be?"

The sword shakes in her hand, and she even starts to lift it up, as if to make a chopping motion toward my head, but finally, she drops it and falls to the ground, clutching her chest as she stares at a bloody patch of grass nearby.

"Weak... but loyal. I see. I would have respected your choice either way."

My throat doesn't hurt as much anymore, telling me that my regeneration is really kicking in now. A quick glance at the hole in the Supreme Commander's chest tells me his wound is starting to heal. If I'm unlucky, that neutralization field will activate again, and I'll have to hit him with another pebble. I don't think either of us would survive that.

I reach over and place my hand on his forehead. *I'm sorry, other-me. You have something that I want, and I need answers now.*

Fine. Do what you must. I hope millions of years of memories make your brain explode.

I waver for a moment at that thought, but quickly shake the feeling off. I don't think this will kill me. At least, I hope not.

" **Transfer.** "

* * *

I open my eyes and stare at the ceiling blankly. Familiar black tiles greet me, as does the sound of people milling about in the distance. I know this place... I've been here before.

A shadow creature walks over to my right side, his chest barely above the level of the bed. I stare at him for several long moments before I register who he is. "Yama?"

"Correct." He stands silently for several long moments before speaking again. "I watched everything. It was delectable how you managed to nearly kill the Supreme Commander of the United Earth Forces with just took a single word, and even his impenetrable defenses couldn't stand up to you."

"Oh. Right." I lean up in bed and stifle a nauseous feeling, before turning to look around the small room. "Where is he? Where's Lora?"

"The slave girl is fine. She's sleeping back in your room. As for the Supreme Commander, I removed his armor and placed him in stasis. To think you were considering killing such a valuable hostage..."

"I was only considering. That didn't mean I was actually going to do it." I twist around and shimmy off the bed, cracking my knuckles and yawning as I do so. "How long was I out?"

Yama takes a few steps back as I stand up to my full height, towering over him. "Half a day, in human time. What you did was foolish. If I weren't there, the commander would have eventually healed himself, and you would have been an easy target. You were lucky."

I stare past Yama at the wall thoughtfully. "Strange. I tried to download his memories into mine, but I don't remember anything. My head hurts like sin, though."

"The human mind is an enigma. Give it time, I'm sure they will surface. In the meantime, we have had quite the fortunate series of events."

"Oh really? Do you mean the capturing of humanity's highest commander?"

Yama nods as we walk out the door, with him leading the way up the hall toward the direction of the dining area. "To an extent. However, we're doubly lucky. You look and sound just like the Supreme Commander, meaning you could even... take his place."

Now I'm surprised. "Take his place? You're saying you want me to lead humanity."

"You're a smart fleshbag." Yama mutters to himself for a minute, and soon we arrive at a doorway I haven't been to since I arrived here. When he pushes the door open, I'm greeted once more by tools and implements of various sizes and shapes, some of them being for construction, but others are for torture. Those aren't what catch my eye though. It's the large blue crystal that glows in the middle of the room, one with a young girl trapped inside, her long black hair trapped in various positions to and fro, her eyes closed as if she's accepted her fate.

And beyond the girl, there are other crystals in the room, each of them housing different humans, even a demon or two. One of those crystals has the Supreme Commander inside of it. He's grievously injured, and the hole in his chest has stopped healing due to the stasis effect, but I can tell he's still alive.

"What is this room? Who are these people?"

Yama raises a hand to silence me. "This is a distinctive room, one of my favorites. I've killed slaves for daring to peek in here, but it's time you learned of its existence. Here is where I house my final defense against humanity. I have captured a few of their greatest individuals, and I hold them here to use them as a bargaining chip, should humans ever press too greedily on my domain."

"Hmm. A good plan, I guess." I want to ask something else, but the way Yama lingers near the girl with the black hair, staring up at her face with a content look on his face... it disturbs me. "Is she someone important to you?"

He immediately snaps his head back to look at me. "It's none of your business. In any case, I wanted you to see the Supreme Commander for yourself. I will keep him here, and you will go and take his place."

I examine Yama incredulously for a minute before shrugging. "This is a terrible idea. I won't be able to convince anyone I'm him if I can't remember anything."

"Agreed. You had best get to scouring his memories, then. Go to sleep for a while, and maybe that will bring them swimming to the surface."

"Hmm." I grunt to myself and turn to stare at the man encased inside a crystal. He doesn't look like he's in pain now, and seems quite serene.

Finally, I don't have to work my ass off anymore. I can just sleep for a while, take a break. This isn't even a punishment, you idiots.

I feel a voice speak in my head, but it isn't the commander speaking to me. Instead, it's more of a feeling, like a memory from the past. Maybe I'm finally tapping into something from his memories.

"Sleep well, Commander. I'll take over from here."

I turn around and walk away, giving a passive wave at Yama as I do so. Neither of us says anything, as both of us hate goodbyes.

Several long minutes pass as I trudge down hallways and corridors, aiming for my room where Lora is waiting. I think about a great many things, including the battle, the past, and the future ahead of me. I don't know what life the Supreme Commander has lived, but his choices during our conflict tell me a lot about his character. He values the law, above all other things. I suppose if he were to assign arbitrary values to himself, they would be Truth, Justice and the American Way.

As I expected, from another me.

I walk up to my door and stop as I spot Lora sitting on the edge of the bed, her shoulders slumped, her armor in a pile in the corner of the room, and a somber expression on her face as she stares at the floor. The feeling she exudes is immediately apparent; depression. I killed a friend of hers in a very violent manner. Now she's going to sleep with me, and there's no way she will be able to look at me the same way ever again.

"Lora. I'll ask you again, do you hate me?"

She stays in the same position for several seconds before finally nodding slowly.

"I understand. Truth be told, I don't know why I killed Sylvia in the way I did. It popped into my head, in the heat of the moment. I won't apologize because that would cheapen her

sacrifice."

I slowly walk over and sit down next to Lora, wrapping my arm around her back. She doesn't pull away. "What I did was wrong, according to most people's sense of morality. However, I have always said that failure is not an option. Do you understand that?"

She nods.

"Glad to hear it. I will do you a small courtesy, just this once. I'm going to make you forget about your friend. You will not forget her death, but instead, any relationship you ever had with her. She will just be a random nobody that I killed. In time, I'm sure you will look at her in the same manner as I do."

She pulls away from me and looks at me with a disbelieving expression.

"It's not optional. I just wanted you to know why I'm doing this... even though you won't remember in a few moments. You'll thank me later."

The irony doesn't escape me that I refused to remove her memories of her childhood, but my reasoning is different this time. Those memories should eventually shape her into a brutal, cunning fighter. The memories of Sylvia would only serve to weaken her loyalty to me. And that is unacceptable.

She pulls away from me, but I grab her arm and touch my hand to her forehead. "You're my slave. Never forget that. I give, and I take away. **Forget.** "

* * *

The four guards stand and stare down the hallway, as they always do during their shifts. Small talk isn't uncommon, but they usually lower their voices, and always keep their eyes peeled.

"My feet are killing me." Private Louse speaks up, shifting uncomfortably on his feet. "We should rotate shifts every two hours. Four hours or longer is just too much."

Another guy nods. "You said it. The darkness has a way of making your sanity slip away. Would it hurt them to at least give us some light?"

Both of them steal a glance at the warp gate in the rear. "Not like demons can activate it without the code. You'd think automated sentries would do the job."

"Cheh. I wouldn't trust a clanker as far as I could throw it. You know what the Volgrim have told us."

"You don't trust robots, but you believe alien propaganda? You're an idiot. The Volgrim just don't want us to advance AI because then we'll be a threat."

Another guy pipes up. "Quiet down. You guys never stop bickering, every goddamned day. Just once I'd like a shift where I get to sit and enjoy some silence."

"Piss off, Riker. You're a real creepy guy. You should learn how to talk more. It'd make you less of a loner."

The fourth guard raises his rifle slightly. "Something's coming. There's a blip on the radar."

"Shit." They turn and watch, before finally hearing the sound of footsteps. *Two sets*, One of the guards thinks to himself.

From the darkness, two pale armored commandos step out, walking casually towards them. Their body language doesn't show any sign of hostility, but the guards keep their rifles trained on the newcomers.

"Commandos, huh? State your names and ranks, as well as your expedition code."

Both figures walk slowly until they stop about twenty feet away. The commando in the front reaches up and his helmet slides open. "I am Supreme Commander Jason Hiro. I trust that will do?"

All the guards look from one to another in disbelief. "Uhh, with all due respect, we never saw the Supreme Commander enter the labyrinth. How do we know you're not a shapeshifting demon?"

The commander stares at them for a few seconds, as if he's pondering something, before finally stroking his beard. "Demons can't win against hypersuits. If I were a demon, I'd have to be powerful enough to kill a commando, and all the S-ranked demons are gone. But if you want more proof, I do have my biometric data."

He walks forward, and the guards quickly go over a few scans before pulling back in surprise. "C-Commander Hiro! We didn't realize you were here! Sorry about detaining you, sir."

"It's fine. I'm proud to call such efficient men and women part of my military. You'll go far in life." He grunts at them and his suit closes up a moment later, but one of the men glances toward the other suited figure. "What about that guy?"

"That *guy* is a VIP. I was here on a diplomatic mission, and I was able to rescue a civilian. I placed *her* inside of a hypersuit for her protection. I'm sure you understand."

"Right, of course, sir. We do need her biometric data to ensure she is, in fact, human, commander."

The commander crosses his arms and seems displeased, but finally, he waves his hand. "Fine. Go ahead."

A quick scan later, and one of the men raises an eyebrow in surprise. "She's 15% Goldeshian. Furthermore, she's part of... *that* sect. I thought we... err..." He pauses to stare at the Supreme Commander. "...ah, never mind. It's your business, sir. Anyway, you're cleared to pass."

"Naturally." The Supreme Commander pushes through and arrives at the warp gate as they fire it up for him. "I wonder what's in store for us now, Lora."

Part 398b:

"Supreme Commander Hiro, the UEF Mothership is cleared for landing. Please proceed to the designated docking point marked on your display in three minutes, five seconds."

The robotic voice speaks to me, and I fiddle with the display console commands. Every time I look at something or interact with a computer, a fragment of memory surfaces, allowing me to remember how it works. The 'Supreme Commander' indeed had many memories stored, but it seems they will only appear in my mind if I'm reminded of them by something external, like a comment someone directs at me about the past, or when I look at something he considered significant.

Lora sits in the seat beside me, and she's been silent as always during the trip. She seems cold and distant, ever since I erased her memory, but not unfamiliar. It's like she's avoiding me, but not intentionally. I've probed her mind and found no memory of Silvia, so it can't be that she hates me for any reason involving the child.

I scratch my chin thoughtfully while the ship slowly moves forward at impulse power to glide into its designated docking platform. Why did I kill Silvia? Yes, she failed me... but was that a good reason to do so? Something about my action was distinctly not something I would normally do. It was almost as if something or someone was influencing me.

Not that it was the wrong thing to do. Far from it, I just don't think I would usually waste a pawn for no reason. At least Silvia's death gave me the perfect distraction to take out the Supreme Commander.

I grunt and let the thoughts slip away. They don't matter. Silvia's gone, and even if I cloned her from my memory, she wouldn't be the same person anymore, she'd just be a mindless object.

Instead, I turn my attention to the hangar before us. Up ahead, several dozen people are clustered together at the platform my ship is aiming for. "Computer, can you zoom in on those people? I want a better look."

A single beep answers my request, and the screen zooms in to enhance. I stare blankly at them for a minute while the ship makes its landing corrections, and eventually the memories of each one bubble up to the surface, though I only get names and a superficial idea of their personality instead of any profound memories or life history.

Even despite these limitations, I quickly realize that the Supreme Commander never knew these people all that well. They're just low-level bureaucrats, and the word 'kiss-ass' comes to

mind. I can probably ignore them and keep my cool, but I'll be polite, just in case.

Lora closes up her helmet, and I take mine off, though I keep wearing my hypersuit. I copied both of our suits from what the other Jason wore and repaired them to restore their functionality. I have to say that they're quite beneficial. The protection isn't much different from my invisible suit that I wear at all times, but somehow wearing something more akin to a light armor makes me feel more protected. It's nothing major, but it makes a psychological difference to me.

The ship lands and Lora and I make our way down the steps., One of the leaders steps forward quickly, but I notice a few of the others behind her flash a tinge of irritation at how she jumped ahead of the pack. "Supreme Commander! We're so glad you made it back safely! How did your foray into the labyrinth go?"

I keep my expression neutral, unsure if I should be friendly or curt. Best to play it safe until I get a better feel for how he interacted with other people. "Adjunct Denara, it's good to see you as well. My mission was a success, and I found what I was looking for."

Not a single person looks at Lora. She's just an ordinary bodyguard, too unimportant for them to care. Denara's smile sweetens, and she takes a few steps closer, closing the gap between us as I step off the docking ramp. "So the diplomatic effort was a success then? Were you able to finally find common ground with the demons? Or did they stubbornly cling to their warlike ways?"

Is that the cover story? The other Jason went there to fight me, so he must have kept my identity secret from everyone else. Why? Maybe he didn't know where my allegiances were directed? Even so, to lie to other world leaders...

"You know demons; they're so stubborn." I give a neutral answer, neither confirming nor denying anything, but I see the gears turning in her head as she makes my words fit whatever preconceived response she expected.

"Oh yes, of course we do! It was unfortunate, but demons will be demons after all!"

A man from the back steps forward. "Denara, please save some of the greetings for the rest of us. Commander Hiro, it is an honor to finally meet you. I am-"

I interrupt him. "Thomas Willard. Yes, of course. I have heard of you in passing."

My memories of the man are very faint, and judging by the fact he mentioned never meeting me, he and the other Jason must never have had any formal contact, though my knowledge of his background does hold more than I might expect from someone who is barely an

acquaintance. The original Supreme Commander must have done his homework on every politician across the galaxy. He was very thorough.

Thomas grins at me. "I'm impressed! I hadn't expected you to know my name before we even spoke to each other! Do you have a retinal scanner, perhaps? That would be cheating!"

I smile pleasantly at him. "No need for cheating, Mister Willard. I didn't become Supreme Commander by being lazy."

More of the politicians in the back push up to speak with me, and I quickly hide a grimace. Truthfully, I don't give a damn about these idiots. They're just wasting my valuable time. I decide to make my move. "Apologies to everyone here, but I am exhausted. I have been away for a while and would like very much to head home and get some rest."

Disappointment crosses over all of their faces at once, but they nod universally, being very understanding of my situation. Denara coughs into her fist. "Sir, before you head home, there was an urgent matter to attend to regarding the Liarus system. I'm sure the acting Auxiliary Commander would have gotten to it, but your deft touch is always a bonus."

I nod slowly. "Alright. Thank you for the information. I'll just... uh... head to my..." I struggle to think of where I work, but Denara, ever the helpful one, fills in the blank for me.

"We sent the information to your assistant, Stephanie. It will be at your office."

"My office, right. Thank you, Adjunct Denara."

I quickly pull away from the group of people, and Lora follows behind me silently.

"Christ. This Commander is a busybody. He's just way too popular. I can't process all of his memories at once, and new ones are slow to arrive."

Lora simply nods as she falls into stride beside me, but I can't see her expression thanks to the helmet hiding her face.

I glance down at my wrist, where a holographic communicator is sitting. I tap it curiously, and nothing happens. A moment later, the other Jason's memories appear, and I realize how to use it. "Morris, where is my office located?"

The suit silently pops up a holographic map in midair, hovering above my wrist, with an arrow pointing to a direction forwards and to the right slightly, at an elevator shaft.

"Oh. Handy." I raise my eyebrows at the technological marvel and wonder to myself what a future tens of millions of years after I was born will be like. It must be a utopia if humanity is still around and no major wars are ongoing. Other than the demons of course, but even I can see the demons are a non-issue.

Lora and I step into an elevator, and it begins to descend to the planet surface beneath us. Earth awaits.

* * *

I switch off my holographic map once it points straight ahead down a hallway where my destination awaits. The space on the map is impressively big, so naturally, I'll be able to find it now that I'm on the same floor. It's a salaryman's dream come true; the perfect corner office.

A minute of walking passes, and soon I arrive at a desk where a young woman is sitting, her thin framed glasses sitting lightly on her nose as she flicks through her datapad. She's a frumpy young thing, wearing a plaid shirt and black slacks, and her black hair is pulled back into a tight bun. I stare at her for several seconds before she looks up and jerks back in surprise. "O-oh! Supreme Commander! I didn't realize you were back yet!"

Her name pops into my head, along with other details. "Stephanie, I see you've been... hard at work."

Mental impressions of disdain enter my mind. The other Jason thought his assistant was a lazy slacker, but he's always taken it easy on her because of her life circumstances. What a pushover.

"I'm sorry, Commander Hiro, I just didn't know you were coming back today! Your office is all cleaned up, so go ahead and head on in."

"I will." I continue walking onward and arrive at the doorway to my office, with Lora still very much in tow. I feel Stephanie's gaze filled with curiosity as she examines the person wearing the commando armor beside me, but she doesn't ask who the suited person is. Good, I'd rather not answer.

I stare at the door, but nothing happens. Every other door in the building opens automatically, but not this one?

"Uh, open. Activate. Engage." I speak, but it stubbornly stays shut. I start to ask Stephanie what's wrong, but a robotic male voice responds.

"You are not an authorized visitor."

Stephanie stands up at the desk abruptly, a look of worry on her face. "Oh shoot, the door isn't opening? I'm sorry, commander, just try using the override code. I thought the door was in perfect working order!"

I lick my lips and wait for a few seconds, and the activation code comes to mind. "Computer, I am Supreme Commander Jason Hiro. The override code is Delta-Niner-Tango-Omicron."

A low beep sounds off. "You are not an authorized person. Only the Supreme Commander may enter this room or approve visitors."

Stephanie quickly hustles over to me, a guilty expression on her face. "I'm sorry, Commander. Samuel's not usually like this. I'll have a maintenance crew investigate the issue as soon as possible."

A bead of sweat drips down my face. "Can you allow me inside, Stephanie?"

She stares at me for a few seconds, then blinks. "Oh, of course! You gave me clearance when you left! Sorry, I'm just so forgetful!" She quickly looks up at the ceiling. "Samuel, access please."

A cheerful beep. "No problem, Miss Guillermo! You are an authorized guest!"

The door whooshes open, and she takes a step back. "There you go! Sorry about the confusion, I don't know why he's doing this."

I shrug nonchalantly. "It's fine. Just make sure you get a maintenance crew on it. I don't want to go through this every day."

She nods, and Lora and I step inside the room, while the door closes behind us.

I take in the sights. It's a reasonably spacious office, with enough space to throw down two executive tables with dozens of chairs worth of seating room. The office window has a fantastic view outside, and I can see thousands of towering skyscrapers all around for miles and miles in every direction.

I am on Earth. It's been dramatically changed from before I entered my cryopod, but I can't mistake it for anything else. The sun beats down from outside, but the temperature controls have the room set to the perfect temperature. I walk over to my desk, tucked off in the corner, and beckon to a chair across the chamber. "Go have a seat, Lora. I'm going to try and figure out what the hell is going on."

She walks over and pats the seat in surprise, likely at how comfortable it looks, then sinks into it. I'm sure if she wasn't wearing her helmet, she'd breathe a sigh of relief.

I reach over to a terminal and tap on it, my fingers moving on their own as the other Jason's practiced movements show up in my memory. When the password comes up, I type on the floating keys without thinking about it. *Rosebud*. What a queer password.

A vast network of files appears before me, all of them sorted into neat categories and such, but I stare at them for two long minutes as I debate what to look into first.

Finally, I go for the one labeled *State of Affairs*. Pictures and images pop up as I quickly scroll past them. I quickly spot the current date, 45,153 L.Y. which means nothing to me. I

already know from the other Jason's memories that he is several million years old, I just don't know precisely how long it's been since I entered the cryopod.

Several headlines grab my attention. *Volgrim tensions are increasing. Mass extinction on Fennors II. Solar winds expected to double Dyson output for the next two centuries.*

I read for a long while, but my head starts to hurt and soon I'm ready to fall asleep. There's just too much to process. The universe is in an entirely different place from when I was born. It's like I'm in the twilight zone.

The computer overhead makes an alert sound, and the previous Jason's memories of that ping tell me there's a visitor at the door. Christ, can't anyone leave me alone for once?

"Come in."

I wait, but nothing happens. Then I remember the issues with the door. I tap my wrist communicator. "Stephanie, can you let in whoever's at the door?"

She doesn't respond, but a moment later the door opens, and a redhead wearing thick brimmed glasses walks in, as Stephanie beats a hasty retreat in the background.

This time, my memory recognizes the person immediately. She's someone the other Jason interacted with on a regular basis. Marie Becker, the head of the engineering department. A veritable genius, it would seem.

"Miss Becker, great to see you again."

She pauses her walking toward me to raise an eyebrow. "Miss Becker? My my, aren't we formal today?" She casts a glance at my suit and then over to Lora sitting in the corner. "What's with the getup, and who's the stiff?"

I shake my head quickly. "Oh, come on, I just got back. No need for so many questions. I'm very fatigued."

"Uh huh... right." There's a hesitation in her voice as she once again continues walking forward, stopping a few feet from my desk. "I came as soon as I heard you were back. Have you gotten around to the Liarus request? They were asking for supplies and help to repair damage caused by the megaquake off their coast. The death tolls are in the thousands."

I glance down at my holopad on my desk, but see nothing on it. "I don't have that information. Wait, hold on..." I reach over and call Stephanie again. "Hey, Stephanie, did you send me the information on the Liarus system yet?"

There's a pause before her voice responds back frantically. "Oh my gosh! I'm so sorry! I forgot! I'll mail it to you right now!"

I roll my eyes and cut the line. A few moments later, my pad makes a ping sound as the information appears. "That woman... I tell you what..."

I look back up to see Marie staring at me with an odd look in her eyes. "Say, I was wondering, did you manage to find the other Wordsmith? You were gone much longer than anticipated."

I suddenly feel a chill go down my spine. She knows about me? I thought the Supreme Commander told everyone it was a diplomatic mission...

I quickly cough into my glove. "Heh, yeah, funny story. It turned out to be nothing. Just a demon we hadn't seen before. I took care of him."

"Oh? How... unlike you." Her eyes glow with a look I've never seen before, and she quickly speaks up. "Samuel, flush the property. Level 4 clearance."

I suddenly realize my error and jump up out of my seat, but it's too late as the entire room floods with that energy neutralization from before. I stagger back as a wave of nausea and agony overtakes me, making me trip over my chair and fall on my ass. My body begins to feel numb rapidly, and my head spins as well. "M-Marie! Stop! This is treason!"

From the corner of my eye, I see Lora leap from her chair and charge over at Marie, but the woman just taps something on her belt and Lora stumbles, falling face-first into the carpet.

"Shut up. Which one are you, and what did you do with Jason 12F?"

Part 399b: Source

A flash of movement to my side. As expected, the seated commando is in on this charade. I reach down and tap a button on my belt, which sends an emergency short range hypersuit deactivation signal. The Commando flops to the ground uselessly as his suit turns against him, giving me a comical moment that would make me laugh if I had a sense of humor.

I pivot to face the fake Jason. "Which one are you, and what did you do with Jason 12F?"

The fake groans in pain and clutches his stomach for a moment, but even then his arms flop to the side. He's losing control of his motor skills, and fast.

"Marie, stop this! We're supposed to be on the same team!"

He thinks I'm an idiot. How sloppy can this Jason get? Of course I'd be on high alert when the second Source Jason goes out to have a chat with an unauthorized arrival. Coupled with all the other signs, like being too formal with me, and the door not opening for him, it was all too obvious this wasn't 12F.

The question I have to ask is... who? Which version is he? Is he a B or a C? Dispatching a pacifist like 12F is the simplest thing possible, so it's not as if his combat capabilities have to be high. He didn't even know who I was, though, so how could that be?

"Why didn't you check in with me when you arrived here? You should understand proper vetting protocol."

He looks at me with those miserable, pleading eyes. I can tell... he hasn't a clue what he's doing. He's way too green for a Jason. I've seen some dumb variants, but I've also seen some terrifyingly intelligent ones. This one is different though. It's not so much a lack of intelligence, as a lack of experience.

"Protocol? Marie... I can't... you're killing me..."

I roll my eyes and flick a cigarette out of my shirt pocket. This is going to be a long day. I light it with the experience of tens of millions of years of practice, wasting no time. "Oh, I'm so sorry. I'll just go ahead and release the anti-energy field so you can have this attack dog tear me to pieces." I turn and kick the Commando in the gut, though I'm sure he didn't feel a thing.

Jason's eyes follow my foot. "Leave Lora alone; she's no threat to you!"

"Answer my questions, then. I couldn't care less about her."

His eye twitches and he looks away guiltily. "F-fine, you caught me... I'm not the Jason you know..."

Oh? He's learning his place quickly. "I already guessed as much. What I want to know is where you come from. No Jason would ignore the first contact protocol, it's important for maintaining continuity. You're either stupid, ignorant, or lazy."

Or all three. I keep that thought to myself.

He bites his lip and shoots a look over at the Commando on the floor. Does this Jason think she's going to rise to the task of saving him? The whole point of a hypersuit emergency shutdown is that it disables the wearer's brain signals. Not that I'd expect him to know that since even 12F didn't know about my back door kill command...

Finally, he looks at me. "I don't know what you mean. The other Jason attacked me, so I killed him. I'd barely even been awake for a few weeks."

I have an urge to shove this cigarette right up his ass. "You killed him...?! God fucking dammit- you idiot! Why would you kill him?! He was just there to find out what you were doing!"

Jason's body slumps even more. It appears he's going numb everywhere. "I don't know what you think he was doing, Marie, but he threatened the life of one of my allies, so I took action. I'm sorry he was your friend, but he was in my way."

I raise an eyebrow. "Friend? I wouldn't go that far. He was, however, a critical asset to me. How did you kill him, anyway?"

The little shit sneers at me. "I'll tell you if you turn off the radioactive death beam and let us talk like ordinary people."

"I'll consider that later." I rub my forehead and take a drag from my cigarette. "Stay here and don't cause trouble. I'll be right back."

"Bite me."

What a pleasant variant. He's so ill-tempered.

I exit the room, wait for the door to hiss shut behind me, and reach for my wrist-transmitter. Only then do I remember the assistant girl. "Oh you, over there. Woman with the black hair. The Commander says you can take the rest of the day off. You've earned it."

She was sitting in the chair staring at her holo-watch and chatting with someone out of boredom, but my words immediately brought a little life to her eyes. "Really? Wow, thank you so much, Miss Becker!" She perks up and quickly stumbles out of her chair, a stupid smile plastered across her face the whole time.

"Thank him, later. Go on, then." I watch silently as the bumbling fool grabs her Folding Belt, drops a few items into its vacuum storage, and then trots past me while humming a 'pleasant'

tune.

"Have a great day, Miss Becker!"

"Sure."

Once she's out of eyesight, my eyes roll up into my head of their own accord. I despise menial discussions.

Her chair is open, so, hell with it. I walk over and plunk down, tapping a button and using my personal access code to activate the cameras in the Supreme Commander's quarters. Just in case he gets a little uppity and tries to make a break for it, I'll keep an eye on him. Cheh, like that would possibly work.

With another flurry of movement, I activate my dimensional transmitter and wait silently. The receiver in my wrist transmits for three minutes before someone answers the call. A voice identical to my own speaks back to me, which never stops being a tad unnerving.

"Marie 12F. You're not scheduled for a report for another six months."

"Perhaps I wanted to hear the soothing voices of my twin sisters." I grumble into the receiver. "Listen, I'm having a major issue. Jason 12F has been KIA'd."

Silence for five long, awkward seconds. "If this is a prank..."

"Do you think I'd risk calling HQ over an unsecured line as a joke? I don't even have time to get back to my office. It gets worse though."

"Go on."

"There's a new Jason in my office. He claims he killed 12F, but he's acting very odd. He didn't remember the first contact protocol, he's sloppy, and he barely even knows who I am. I suspect he copied 12F's memories into his own, and he was planning to take 12F's place before I caught him."

The other Marie swallows audibly. "That is *very* concerning. 12F was supposed to be a Source Jason. How could he have been killed? It could destroy the continuum if that were the case."

I lick my lips and tap my cigarette's ashes on the floor beside me absentmindedly. "I think... I believe... this new Jason might also be a Source as well. Just a hunch."

After a few seconds, HQ Marie cackles. "Hah! Now I know you're messing with me! Saint Helen on Earth, how long were you going to draw this out? We already recognize there can only be two Sources. Alpha Jason confirmed it himself, and three is just absurd."

"He did... I know that... but could he have lied? Would he?"

Another long pause. "You really think this is a third, seriously? Look, it isn't possible. All of the data points to two Sources. I refuse to believe it. He's one of the Travelers, and he's messing with you. That's all there is to it. Alpha Marie would have my ass if she found out I even entertained this silly notion."

"What if she's lying too? This could go deeper than we thought." I finish off my cigarette and stab it onto the assistant's desk. I don't care if it leaves a mark since the janitor bots will just clean up any messes later.

"So you think there's some elaborate conspiracy? I'll talk with the others and get back to you, but for now, you're on your own. If you think he's a third Source, then you'd damn well better treat him like one. No divulging information he shouldn't know. You already have Source training, so it should be a snap."

My jaws slackens. "Are you implying I should give him the red carpet treatment? He killed 12F! We have a delicate balance to uphold! This is the only universe where total peace is a possibility! Isn't that worth something?"

"Oh *please*, spare me the crap, Marie 12F. There's no such thing as total peace. The work camps alone are pretty heinous compared to what other clusters have achieved. Don't pat yourself on the ass too hard. HQ out."

My transmitter disconnects and I force myself to maintain my calm while watching the man on the screen shift around slightly on the floor.

All my work, everything I've put into this galaxy over millions and millions of years... I created the perfect diplomatic machine, and now some callous idiot is going to ruin it all. He's grossly inferior to 12F. I can't accept it. I won't!

I stand up and disable the video feed, then stride back into the room. Naturally, he's sitting there in the same spot as before, though now his head has lolled so far to the side that it looks like he's halfway napping.

He grimaces once he spots me. "I hope you had a good piss."

"Stuff it." I flash my middle finger at him before looking up at the ceiling. "Samuel, shield the flock. Level 4 clearance."

I don't feel any changes, but Jason's entire attitude shifts as he tries to stand up and instead falls forward on his face. He pulls himself back up by holding onto the desk, and then he stares at me questioningly. "You're... letting me go?"

"Not a chance. I've done some digging, and found you're a wanted man. If you ever want to lead a traditional life, you'll do as I say and take responsibility for your actions."

"A wanted man?" He rubs his arms and stands up a little straighter as the numbness wears off in his body. "You're screwing with me."

Yep. I smile inwardly. "No. I'm very serious. I never joke around. Since you killed Jason 12F, this galaxy will likely fall into instability, and I'll have a big mess on my hands. You're going to have to stand in for him and take his place until I can work out a more... permanent solution."

He scowls at me, and his body tenses up. "You mean prison."

"I mean many things. Your future is in your hands."

I notice something slowly hover up and in front of him. It looks like a pebble, though perfectly round in an uncanny way. A secret weapon, then?

He chuckles. "Maybe I should kill you now."

"Oh yes, by all means, try me. I think you'll find the others will not be as nice as I am. You have more enemies than friends right now, having killed a fellow Jason. If you eliminate me, the footage of my death and you speaking about killing the actual Supreme Commander will be broadcast to the rest of this galaxy, so every human, angel, and Volgrim will be your enemy. I recommend you tread carefully, insect."

A bead of sweat drips down the back of my neck. In truth, I don't know what this one will do. Something about him is unhinged compared to other Jasons. I'd rather not die and end up an angel as that would cause me a lot of grief, but one cannot back down when confronted by a god with childlike intelligence. It's better if I use my overwhelming intellect to make him doubt his perception of reality.

The pebble slowly lowers and enters a bag at his waist. Fascinating, I hadn't noticed that small cloth sack before. Are pebbles his primary weapons? I wonder how he uses them.

"Christ. You think of everything, don't you?" He gnashes his teeth and glares at me. I can already see he's going to be an unwilling participant, but I don't need him to be happy with my orders, merely compliant. "The other Jason thought highly of you. I keep getting flashes of the past whenever you talk."

"Ah, so you did copy his memories. That may have just been the most intelligent thing you've done up to this point. I won't have to educate you on every menial piece of the galaxy's political situation."

He crosses his arms and leans against the desk. "I didn't say I'd help. I don't stand to gain anything from this."

"If you flee, I'll have all of humanity hunt you down. If you kill me, I'll still have all of humanity hunt you down. You might not have anything to gain, but you have everything to

lose."

I tap my belt, allowing the Commando beside me to regain consciousness. "You be a sweet girl and don't do anything idiotic."

It takes half a minute for her to start moving again, having been knocked out by the suit's defensive systems, but eventually, she drags herself up, and her faceplate hisses open. She doesn't say a word though, making me raise an eyebrow.

"No witty comeback?"

"Lora can't speak. The demons turned her into a mute." Jason helpfully fills in the gap for me, which makes me smile for once.

"She's already my kind of human. Someone who can't talk back is infinitely more valuable than one who blubbers."

A chuckle wheezes out of his throat. "Heh, funny, I had the same thought myself. Maybe we're not so different."

I glance down at my wrist-transmitter and note the time. "Don't get ahead of yourself. We have a lot of work in front of us. So, are you in, or do I have to put you in your place once more?"

He waves his hand flippantly. "I'm in. Whatever. It's not like I care. I just want to find out what's going on in the universe."

"Hmm. Right." I reach for another cigarette in my pocket, but pause and sigh. I don't want to waste these. They take too long to grow. "I do have one last question for you... you mentioned only being awake for a few weeks. What did you mean by that?"

Jason pulls away from the desk and walks toward Lora. "I woke up inside a cryopod a few weeks ago. It was inside of the Labyrinth, and I managed on my own for a short while until the demons took me in."

"*Oh*. Well, that just raises even more questio-" I catch myself mid-sentence and remember something from a very long time ago. "Wait... a cryopod..."

My god... I might be right. If he emerged from a cryopod, it's possible he could be a Source after all. Everything my fellow Maries have been told could be a lie. What are the other possibilities? A clone? A memory wiped Traveler? A demon fake? All could be true, but a second Source might be the case as well.

I don't have all the required information. I need to do digging to find out where he came from, but I can't let on how important he might be. If he knows I can't kill him, he's liable to be a loose cannon.

This puts me in a tough position. "Jason, I'll let you get back to doing... whatever it is you feel like. For now, I just want you not to be irresponsible. The Supreme Commander has many allies, but also many enemies. Keep on your toes. I'm sure you already know how to contact me, so just ask if you have questions. I'll be in touch."

"If I must." He waves his hand at me dismissively. "See ya."

"So polite." I turn and walk out of the room, secretly wondering to myself if I've made a mistake in leaving him to his own devices.

After I've walked down the hallway a bit and I'm far from earshot, I speak up towards the ceiling. "Samuel, let the hive know if the bees whisper."

The computer chimes audibly. "No problem, Head Engineer, Marie Becker!"

I need to find the cryopod he woke up from. It holds the answers.

* * *

Steven Feldmann relaxes in his apartment as he watches the local cluster's news network. Absolutely nothing of interest is on, so the anxious looking reporter is being forced to stretch the local weather report into a twenty-minute time-slot.

Feldmann adjusts his robe as he lounges on his couch. *What's the point of telling me the weather, anyway? It's always the same. That's the whole point of the Atmospheric Conditioners. This guy's just wasting his time, not that I can blame him.*

Finally, boredom takes over, and he climbs off his couch to go stare out at the same generic sunny day that he's seen a billion times, quite literally.

Everything feels so empty, these days. The kids are all grown up, the wife isn't here half the time, the demons are a pittance of a threat... the meaning of life is so hollow, in the end. Nothing matters.

He paces into the kitchen, and both of his cats jump up on the counter and meow at him, but he pushes them aside and starts to assemble the ingredients for a tasty chicken vegetable soup.

Home-made. That's the way to do it. Not using these worthless food reconditioners. Who wants to eat recycled gunk anyway? If I want to stuff some guy's shit in my mouth, I'll find a public toilet.

He taps a button to close his windows, just in case a probe drone happens to pass outside. Even if he's caught using fresh vegetables, the punishment will be fairly minor, but it can't hurt to be careful. As a military general at the highest level of government, it would be a devastating blow to his career to be caught committing even a petty crime. He might be demoted and never have a chance to recover his status.

He glares at the avocado in his hands, before carefully cutting the core out of it. *You'd think they could make exceptions for people at the top of government, but nooo, the Supreme Commander thinks everyone should be equal. What a joke. I don't even know why I try to be competitive anymore, other than the fact I used to enjoy the view from my balcony. I probably just don't want to end up in the lower level apartments. I hear the smog has gotten worse, as if that were possible.*

He begins ripping out the good stuff from the innards of the vegetable, but his personal AI gives him a special alert.

"General Feldmann, there is a high priority call on the line for you. Will you take it?"

He grumbles audibly but sighs and sets the avocado down. "If it's high priority, I have to. Put it on- wait, give me a second."

He quickly shoves the vegetable behind a box on his counter before looking across the counter to his main viewscreen. "Okay, now."

The viewscreen switches and a black haired young woman appears. A look of satisfaction appears on his face. "Ah, Stephanie Guillermo. It has been a while, hasn't it? You must have something to report."

She bats her eyes and smiles sweetly. "Oh yes, I certainly do. As you probably know, the Supreme Commander took a vacation recently."

"Mhm. Continue."

She leans forward and winks knowingly. "Well, as it happens, Commander Jason came back today, and something was very off about him. He was acting out of the ordinary. At first, I thought he was drunk, but now I'm not too sure. The door to his office didn't recognize his biological signature, and when I let him in... Marie Becker showed up shortly after and went in to see him."

Feldmann nods and reaches for the avocado, not caring if the woman on the screen sees. "You think something's going on?"

"I know it. I've worked for the Supreme Commander for years. Marie Becker sent me home, so I didn't get to see what happened next, but I suspect there might be collusion of some sort. I can't offer any details as I wasn't privy to their conversations, but..."

"No no, that is good enough. That wouldn't be the only odd thing that's happened this week. Admiral Danis was acting differently at all three meetings between the joint chiefs. He felt hollow, as if he wasn't really in the room with the rest of us. It was just a feeling, but this..."

He reaches for a carrot and starts dicing it up. "I'll have the next crate dropped off at the usual place. Good work, Steph. I'll continue counting on you, in that case."

He turns his attention back to his food but quickly realizes she hasn't hung up yet. "Is there something else?"

She fidgets slightly. "If possible, can you make sure there are cherries in this next shipment? I've been craving them lately."

Feldmann smiles knowingly at her. "If you keep delivering, so will I. Sayonara."

"Thanks, Steven. You're the best." The line clicks off and Feldmann shakes his head.

What is this, revenge of the bodysnatchers? Something ain't right on Earth, but I'll make it work the way I want it to.

Part 400b: Stranger In A Strange Land

Earth, 45,153 L.Y.

These are numbers that mean nothing to me. I am a part of the future, now, a place where fantasies become a reality. Starships, warp travel, and stratoscrapers that extend miles into the air, almost past the atmosphere itself. The future is a place where all humans are immortal, all diseases are cured, the sky is no longer the limit, and the next advancement is always just over the horizon.

Lora and I amble down the hallway, then step into a futuristic elevator, and a moment later my heart is in my throat as it plunges downward at a terrifying speed. I flinch when I look through the glass floor at the surface of the Earth, miles below us, as it slowly approaches. Behind me, however, the walls of the building where I work at speed past so quickly I can hardly parse their movement. To the sides, I spot hundreds of other glass elevators- no, wait, the memories from the other Jason tell me they're called hover-shafts... anyway, hundreds of other hover-shafts zip past, moving up, down, even a few move sideways too.

Lora has her helmet open, and I shoot a glance over at her. She eyeballs everything around her with the same level of surprise and awe that I do. Despite living in this time, perhaps she lived with the demons her whole life and was never able to experience any of humanity's marvels. A shame.

The shaft slows to a stop, and the door opens up, allowing a thirty-year-old looking woman to step aboard, and based on a mental ping from the other Jason's memories, she seems a little familiar. She immediately salutes when she notices me. "Supreme Commander."

"At ease." The words come out almost mechanically as if they are part of my daily routine. They aren't, of course, it's just the other Jason's memories taking hold. It irritates me to think that he might have any sway over my actions after I defeated him so handily.

I try to ignore the woman, but she seems to want to talk to me, and she keeps glancing between Lora and I. Finally, she gathers the courage and speaks up. "I wanted to thank you, Commander Hiro. What you did for me was very kind."

"Mmm." I grunt quietly and scan her face. Finally, her name appears in my head. "Elsa, wasn't it? Where's the other guy? There was a man with you last time."

She frowns and glances down toward the glass floor beneath us, her brow furrowing as she thinks about it. She looks back up and shrugs. "You mean Brian Andino? He died."

"Oh. Sorry to hear that." I try to force my expression into something compassionate, but fail. I don't care in the slightest what his fate was.

To my surprise, neither does she. "Don't be. I warned Brian over and over not to fool around near the catwalks. Sure enough, he slipped and fell. His body was a puddle on the ground when they found him."

Lora moves slightly, and I turn to notice her dark expression, as she grimaces at this awful news. Even she's more human than the two of us.

I cough into my glove. "Still, losing a friend like that, wouldn't you say it was unfortunate? You don't seem very broken up about it."

She smirks. "I saved a life on the battlefield. That man would have been a loss to the republic. He was a hard worker and fought with his all for the glory of humanity. Brian, however, was a slacker. He's in Heaven now. He'll probably enjoy it more anyway, given he was never really all that interested in working like the rest of us on Earth."

I nod sagely and turn to stare out at the other stratoscrapers in the distance. "Maybe someday, you'll get to see him again."

"Oh, I already did." She leans back against the glass and gestures up to the sky. "Went to visit him in Heaven. He's doing fine. Gave him an earful too."

I take a few moments to blink back confusion as I wonder what she's talking about. "You went to Heaven? Isn't that... a little..."

"Difficult? Not really. I haven't spent my visitation credits for a few thousand years. It used to be harder, but they passed an edict in the last century allowing people to visit with fewer restrictions."

Her response isn't what I was expecting. "O-oh." My mouth gapes for a few seconds, but when I look away, more memories appear in my mind.

Of course, it makes sense now. Heaven is a real place, just as Hell is. It's in another dimension, so visiting it is easily possible if a link is established. All of the details haven't come to me yet, but I feel as if I already get the gist of things.

I scratch my chin and look away nonchalantly. "I've been busy lately, so I might be forgetting something, but can you remind me the state of affairs in Heaven? I just don't have the time to spend learning about the more... *mundane* things in life."

Elsa nods and smiles at me with a cheerful grin. "Oh, certainly! Well, you might not remember, but about two thousand years ago, Zeus opened up his borders, and now angels can

leave Heaven and visit Earth whenever they like. Of course, most don't, due to the shame involved, but-

I interrupt her. "The shame?"

"Yes. After all, an immortal who dies must not have been very intelligent. Death is quite easy to prevent and avoid these days. We don't need people like that clogging up the queues and waiting lines for more competent people. Wouldn't you agree?"

I smile back at her pleasantly. "Yes, actually. The strong deserve more than the weak. Those who carry the biggest load should reap the biggest benefit. That is a fair assessment."

"Humanity's motto hearkens to something similar, commander."

"Oh?" I keep my expression measured, but something in the way she brings that up makes me want to know more. "How so?"

"Don't you remember, commander? I believe you came up with the slogan. ' *For glory, we aspire. Perfection, we achieve. Waste, we prevent. Failure, we despise.* ' A slogan worthy of the might of humanity."

She looks at me questioningly, and I shrug. A quick glance at the hover-shaft's floor-counter indicates we're nearing the bottom. *Finally*. "Uh, that slogan was created by a good friend of mine. I thought it worked well for our glorious empire, so I made the council adopt it."

"That's proof of your leadership! A good boss always listens to his subordinates." She reaches up and pulls back a strand of hair that had sneaked out from behind her ear, then smiles at me before looking over at Lora. "Speaking of subordinates, your friend hasn't said a word since I got on."

Lora stays silent, as expected. I fill in for her. "This is Lora. She has a rare condition, so she'll be getting an operation to fix that. Can't talk until that happens."

"Oh. It must be pretty severe." Elsa lowers her gaze apologetically. "Sorry for bringing it up."

The hover-shaft begins to slow as the bottom approaches and she quickly clears her throat. "Um, anyway, I'm just glad I got to see you again. You put in that word for me, and now I've moved up fifty levels in my complex. We have real food now, though it's only bi-weekly. I had grown so used to rations that I forgot what an apple tasted like!"

I resist the urge to ask what she means. "No problem. Glad I could... help. What was the medal for, again?"

"The medal of courage. Don't you remember?"

I shake my head as the door opens. "I'm just swamped lately. There's a lot on my mind. Have a pleasant day, Elsa."

I beckon with my head slightly, and Lora follows after me out the door. Once it closes, I turn back and watch the lift descend even further. It vanishes from my sight quickly, but we're close enough to ground level now that the only place it could be going at that speed is underground.

The sight outside is unimaginable. I would never have thought as a child that humanity could build such massive skyscrapers. The fact they're called stratoscrapers makes sense. They go far up into the clouds, way beyond a reasonable height. And from the ground level, they fill me with a sense of foreboding, as if a single terrorist bringing one of them toppling down would level the area all around us. Hundreds of them are visible across the landscape, all of their positions plotted out with almost robotic efficiency. How many people live just in a fifty-mile radius from where I stand? A billion? Ten billion?

Humanity has accomplished a lot during the millions of years since I sealed myself away. I feel as if the humans I know now are more alien to me than actual aliens from the TV shows of my youth.

When I turn back to slowly amble down towards the location indicated by my wrist-watch holographic tool thing, whatever it's called, I spot something even more bizarre. Thousands of people are walking around, moving from here to there, all of them looking very busy in general. But scattered in among the humans are... well... angels. I've never seen an angel in my life, aside from literature and television, but without a doubt, they are emphatically what I would imagine angels look like. Their bodies glow slightly, their wings spread out several feet in either direction, and they have a distinctive holy aura about them.

Oddly, wherever an angel stands or walks, people move around them, going out of their way to avoid even the slightest contact. It doesn't look intentional, but more like something trained at a subconscious level. Every human does the same thing. Discrimination? Perhaps something more?

Elsa's words pop back in my mind. *Most don't leave Heaven due to the shame involved...*

Is it shameful to be an angel? How could that be?

My knowledge of the world around me is fragmented. I'm missing bits and pieces, and even whole chunks of information. I still need answers.

Lora and I continue to walk, but finally, we come to a stop, and I scratch my head. Where should I go?

After a long half-minute or so, I pull my watch forward and activate the communicator on it. "Contact Marie Becker."

The computer on my wrist beeps its acknowledgment, and ten seconds later she picks up, audio only. "What do you want? I just left, and already you're bugging me?"

"Yeah. I don't know where I should go."

Her voice has a distinct feeling of annoyance in it. "Did you consider maybe going home? That is, to Jason 12F's residence?"

"I suppose I could. Doesn't quite feel right, though."

"Well, you'll have to deal with 'your' wife when you get there. Sarah and Jason 12F were married for ten million years or so, as part of their official union. Naturally, they've seen a few thousand other people over the eons, but suffice to say their marriage is quite stable, all thing considered."

I nod thoughtfully while vacantly watching people mill around. "So, like, an open marriage? What about 'Until death do you par-', actually, never mind. Immortals."

I can practically hear Marie roll her eyes and nod. "Yeah, yeah. Marriage is a fossilized idea from before the age of nano-technology. Honestly I don't know why Jason 12F even bothered, it's just a formality that doesn't mean anything anymore. Anyway, I'm sure Sarah won't mind if you bring the redhead home with you."

Lora and I both shoot a look of concern at each other. "I don't know, Marie. Can you arrange lodging for Lora some other way? I'd rather not cause any drama in, err, 12F's life... not until I can understand what's going on."

A long sigh. "Saint Joseph and the Holy Grail, do you expect me to do everything for you? I can't be bothered to--"

There's a sudden pause as if an idea blasted into her mind. "...On second thought, I have a plan. I will let the female lodge with me. Keeping her existence a secret will be tough for you, and might even cause you some problems. Jason 12F was gone for over three weeks, after all, and he was only supposed to be gone a few days. Sarah might be annoyed when you show up with a new woman, and she'll inevitably ask questions."

"Oh. That's very kind of you to offer." A feeling of worry fills me with dread. This is almost too convenient. Marie doesn't seem like the kind of woman to offer her help so honestly... maybe she has something to gain from this. "In fact, that's *overly* kind of you. Why are you so nice all of a sudden?"

She scoffs audibly. "Cheh! Here I am offering to do you one little favor, and you're acting like I'm about to steal all the Luciferium in the Nixus vault! If you didn't want my help, you shouldn't have called!"

I wince. "Fine, fine. I was just asking. So... I'll go home, and you take Lora with you. Is that it? No funny business?"

"I own you, Jason. I don't *need* any funny business. One of my associates will be there to pick her up in twenty minutes. Stay put, please."

"Give me a second, and I'll try and tell you where I'm located." I start to look around for signs or something, but she laughs.

"Hah! No need for that, I already know. I always know where you are."

My eyes narrow as I stare at my wrist transmitter. Marie irks me. Getting a handle on her personality is hard.

"Fine. We'll wait. Jason, out."

The communication cuts off, and Lora and I sit on a bench nearby to wait for whoever it is that Marie is sending.

Lora fidgets slightly as a few minutes pass. She doesn't appear keen to leave my side, but it can't be helped. I could use some rest after the mental beating I took from Marie earlier and meeting the woman my doppelganger chose to marry might give me more answers about his personal life. If the worst happens... I can always kill her. This 'Sarah' means nothing to me.

Minutes pass, and Lora is looking more and more anxious. As we wait, an old man hobbles over to us, a sickly patch on an otherwise perfect medley of the ideal humans. While everyone else that passes us and roams around look like men and women in their 30's, the prime of their lives, this grandpa must surely be on death's door. He's dressed in rags too, not at all a sightly figure.

"E-excuse me, boy, might you be willing to let an old man sit? My knees are killing me." Indeed, his legs are trembling, so I nudge Lora to make some room on our bench. He comes over and sits down on the edge, breathing heavily the whole time. It's as if he ran a fifty-mile marathon. I'm just glad he doesn't smell like the embodiment of death.

"You uh... okay, old timer?" I lean away from him slightly as he sways back and forth.

"Yeap, I'm doin' just fine, kid. How about you? You look like you've got a lot stuck in your chaw."

"My chaw?" I stare at him blankly, and he points to his forehead and taps. "Oh. Yeah, I suppose so. I'm the Supreme Commander, you know."

He narrows his eyes and squints at me for several seconds before returning to normal. "Huh. Guess you are. So what?"

He's completely unimpressed by my title. Then again, I'm not even sure what a Supreme Commander does, so I understand the feeling. "Just felt like mentioning it."

"Titles don't amaze me when you spent your life hurtin' people. I ain't a hypocrite though. I did some stuff I regret in my youth. Hurt some folks, broke some laws. Can't take it back, either."

"That's unfortunate." I spare a glance at my watch. There's still ten minutes to go, if this courier person is punctual. I'm probably not that lucky.

"Unfortunate, indeed. And for all the bad things I've done, I live in a society where all my material needs are met. Unfair, ain't it?"

"Unfair? What do you mean?"

My question makes him gesture wildly with his hands. "Look around you. Every one o' these sad sacks has no life ahead of 'em. They're zombies. Even so, they and I get to live these wretched lives, while the people I hurt didn't. We get to choose our deaths when the time comes."

"When you say you 'hurt' people, you mean..."

"Killed, yes. Killed them dead. They took a dirt nap they ain't never gonna wake up from." He reaches up and pulls at the loose skin on his face. "I'll be joinin' 'em soon. A man can only live so many lives before the evils in his past catch up to him."

"You believe your past should decide your future?"

"Of course. It's called karma, son. You reap what you sow. Old fashioned thinking, that's what anyone would say nowadays. I don't think so. Look at every smiling face around us. All of these people have done bad, vile, evil things. The only difference is the degree to which they've committed their crimes. See what I mean?"

I shrug. "Yeah, sure."

He grows silent and doesn't speak for a long thirty seconds. Finally, he coughs. "Welp, that was a good chat. You ain't like the drones all around us. Got a mind of your own, you do."

"I try to stay alert." I nod diplomatically at him. "Thanks for the talk as well, err...?"

"Lee. Name's Lee, kid." He nudges my shoulder with his. "You 'n Lora keep to yourselves now, y'hear? Don't piss the wrong people off. I wanna see you still runnin' the show a week from now. Take care."

He stands up and starts ambling away, leaning on his staff the whole time as I watch.

There's something about that old man. I feel a sudden urge to know more about him. Hesitantly, I reach out with my telepathy and try to read his mind before he leaves my range...

GET OUT OF MY HEAD.

A voice rages in my mind. Images of explosions, children screaming, a man being eviscerated by a beast I've never seen before. A war, bloodier than any conflict the universe has ever seen. Strange automatons firing lasers faster than the human eye can follow. *Let her go!* A little boy sobs as his mother's head is torn from her body.

Images hit me in a way similar to when I read Lora's mind, but far more brutal. In just a single second, my entire body is drenched in a cold sweat, and my hands shake in terror. When I scan the crowd to look for the old man, he's gone.

Before I can ask Lora where he went, a deep voice speaks to my side. "You're Jason Hiro?"

"Huh?" I turn, wild-eyed, to face the speaker. A black-skinned man I've never seen before, with dark black hair and wearing a sharp pinstripe suit, stands out as an elite among the humans around us. "I'm Benjamin Brown. I work for Marie. She sent me here to pick up an asset."

I quickly mop my forehead and twirl around in bewilderment. "Yeah, uh, did you see where that old man went?"

"...Huh?" Benjamin seems irredeemably bored. "Look, just give me the asset. I have work to do."

I finally comprehend his words. "Oh, right. Lora is the girl; she's right here." I point at her. "Marie said to-"

"I know what Marie wants." He grabs Lora forcefully and pulls her out of the chair with a single hand, standing her up before letting go. "Come on, then. You're wasting my time."

Without waiting for a response, he turns around and walks away. Lora turns to look at me, panic evident in her eyes.

"I can see he's an asshole, but bear with it." I stand up and continue looking around. That old man is nowhere in the area, and Lora is the last thing I care about. "I'll see you tomorrow, or whenever. Remember your training, and ditch that armor as soon as you get a chance. I'm sure Marie used it to knock you out. You're still way stronger than an average human, so you can defend yourself."

Lora nods meekly and turns to walk away, but pauses to look at me, a strange longing in her eyes. The moment passes, and she timidly turns and follows after the man.

I hate dramatic goodbyes.

* * *

Huh. So this is it. Room 1, the penthouse suite. Apparently, I own the entire top floor of this megascraper, or rather, the other Jason does. When I look up through the plexiglass ceiling, the blue haze of Earth's atmosphere isn't visible. Unlike the Stratoscrapers, which can reach 50 miles in height, Megascrapers top out around the ten-mile mark, and this one is the most elite of them all, housing the vast majority of humanity's military generals. Everything I look at gives me memory feedback, giving me clues about this and that.

The floors are made of a beige-colored rocky surface, not unlike marble, but somehow even more radiant and beautiful. There isn't a speck of dust to be seen. The walls have been chiseled from limestone, and while most are white, several segments of the walls have artistic patterns colored red, green, and even black. One such pattern depicts a young girl wearing a sundress, colored green, reaching out to touch the claw of a great black dragon. It's foreign in nature, yet I feel as though it's not unfamiliar.

I shake the thoughts from my head and walk forward to knock on the door, catching myself just in time to realize that knocking on my own door would be fairly asinine. Luckily, this door recognizes me, unlike the door to my office, and swishes open silently.

I step inside and examine the entryway that leads directly into my living room. It's a massive space, with a viewscreen running the planetary news which takes up an entire wall, a disgustingly expensive looking glass table that must have cost a fortune, and a large variety of seating implements, none of which look anything like what I'm used to.

I've scarcely started to take the decor into my brain when I hear a deep growling sound to my side. I turn to follow the noise and spot a- SWEET SATAN FATHER IN HELL *that is one big goddamn dog!* An immense black mutt, half the size of an Oldsmobile, with ten beady eyes that are almost spiderlike in appearance, slowly inches toward me from the doorway. His teeth are razor sharp, and each individual claw on his foot is the size of a butcher knife. I might be wearing invisible armor, but this fucker still looks like he could tear me limb from limb.

Just when I've taken him in, the son of a bitch jumps at me. I teleport across the room instantly as a fight or flight instinct takes hold. The hellhound howls at the top of its lungs and five of its ten eyes track onto my position. My heart races and terror takes hold. I've already faced down demons and squads of armed infantry, but nothing prepared me for a monster from the scariest science fiction novels back in my day.

Just as the nightmare beast is about to attack me again, a sweet voice calls out from the other room. "Skippy, what's the matter? Is someone at the door?"

The animal continues to stare me down ferociously but doesn't move a muscle. The voice's source finally enters the room and my mind instantly connects her name to her face. It's Sarah, my lovely wife. Well, the other Jason's wife, but who cares? She's wearing a white satin see-through negligee that shows more than one would normally expect, and my god, she is possibly the most gorgeous looking woman I have ever seen in my life.

I'd be firing on all cylinders plus one if it weren't for the contrast with the horrifying demonic spider-hound that stares me down. I don't know whether to be completely aroused by her or totally frightened by the animal.

She stares at the monster, perplexed for a moment before spotting me. "Oh, Jason, you're finally back! Skippy, you silly willy! That's just daddy!" The animal doesn't back down, and even takes a menacing step towards me, as if it can tell I'm an imposter. Indeed, it is entirely correct.

I could kill it instantly if I wanted. Just one word, even just a hint of telekinesis, and this beast would be downed instantly. But in no way do I wish to upset the woman before me. If I have ever had one single overriding desire as a male, I yearn to taste the honey that falls from that beehive. If killing this disgusting malformed beast would even slightly upset the chance of that happening, I will make sure it lives a long, happy life.

While I think these thoughts, Sarah zips over and throws herself at me, pulling my face to hers and kissing me long and hard. It takes no effort for me to respond to the stimulation and force myself on her, nearly toppling on top of her and falling to the ground. Luckily, the sense of terror in the back of my mind from the werewolf wannabe keeps me from completely losing my sanity as our tongues intertwine.

It takes nearly a full minute, but finally, she pulls away and breathes hard. "Wow, I missed you soooo much! You said it was only going to be a few days! What happened?"

I blink and try to restore a sense of normalcy to my mind. A question. She was asking a question, right. Doing? Me? In the labyrinth? What was it again?

"Uhh, things took a while to resolve. Some crazy stuff happened."

A generic answer, but it seems to be all she wanted to know. "Oh, excellent, I was starting to worry you ended up a casualty or something! Come on, make me some food! I am *starving* for something edible!"

"Huh? Food? What do you mean?" I glance down at her chest and feel like saying something akin to *forget the food! I want to taste you!* but the pouting look on her face snaps me back to reality.

"Just wordsmith 'lasagna' or something! I can't keep eating rations like a commoner, you know! You told me we'd always have the best!"

"Oh... right..." I aim my mind over at the table and mentally picture the most delicious pile of meat, sauce, and cheese a man could ever hope for. " **Lasagna.** "

She squeaks in glee and dives for the table, yet her movement is graceful, almost angelic. Completely ignoring any thought of grabbing silverware, she begins jamming her hands into the concoction and piling the lasagna into her mouth, and immediately my opinions about her beauty and grace are rudely interrupted.

Food turns into chewed food in a manner of time equivalent to microseconds. In less than a minute, Sarah has stuffed half of the lasagna inside of herself in the most disgusting piggish fashion I've ever seen in my life. Only when she pauses to take a breath does her brutal slaughter of the food slow to a crawl. She gasps for breath and turns to me, smiling. Her face and hands are covered in lasagna, and she seems to finally have her wits about her. "Why did Skippy woof at you? He's acting weird."

I don't get a chance to respond. Having paused for breath, she turns back and dives into the rest of the food, her snorting and slurping making my stomach churn. Finally, once she's done, she leans back and pats her stomach contentedly, getting more of the gunk all over her paper-thin clothing. "Clean me!"

"I beg your pardon?"

Her smiles shifts slightly and she sends an odd look my way. " *Come on*, don't make me beg for it! Pleeeeease! Clean me!"

Her request clicks in my mind, so I wordsmith again. " **Clean.** "

Instantly, all the gunk vanishes from her hands, face, and clothing. Once again, she looks radiant and beautiful as before.

But now, something is bothering me. Maybe it's just a faint feeling... simply a hint of trouble... but this doesn't feel right. The way she's acting isn't... normal.

"Okay~! Hey, now that you're home, let's go have sex! Jonathan was just NO good at it! You're the only one who can make me feel good!"

Jonathan? Who is that? Is this the open marriage Marie was talking about?

I walk toward her, and from the corner of my eye that ugly goddamn mauthe doog growls at me, making me flinch in response. I don't care if I can kill it instantly. I apparently have a phobia for giant-ass demon dogs.

Sarah holds up her arms like she wants me to drag her to her feet. Is she helpless? Does she expect me to do everything for her? Still, my male urges relent, so I pull her up, and both of us make our way into the back room.

As we walk through the doorway, I shoot one last look at the abomination behind me. *Your days are numbered, dark one.*

I slam the door behind us with my telekinesis, lock it, and while she isn't paying attention, shove a dresser in front of it.

Just in case.

Part 401b: Trepidation

Master Jason looks around one last time. The old man is gone. I watched him leave... he vanished in just the same way Master does. One moment, he was there, the next he wasn't.

Master turns back to me slowly.

"I'll see you tomorrow, or whenever. Remember your training, and ditch that armor as soon as you get a chance. I'm sure Marie used it to knock you out. You're still way stronger than an average human, so you can defend yourself."

He's distracted and barely even looks at me. For once, I want to say something to make him not send me away, but I still don't have the courage. I silently stare for a few seconds before lowering my head. He wouldn't care anyway. It's fine... this is the best I can get from him right now.

I turn around and hesitantly follow after the dark-skinned man, even as I feel Master's gaze fade from my back. He isn't thinking about my feelings, though he never does. I can't blame him for that. Why would anyone care how a slave feels?

I follow behind the man at a small distance, not wanting to walk beside him. He looks vicious, with eyes that remind me of Danis. Less vile, perhaps, but still cold and unfeeling. We trudge along wordlessly and never once does he look back at me. That's fine... it's better this way.

Benjamin and I travel for nearly an hour in total silence, going up and down wall elevators, as Master calls them, until we arrive at a small, nondescript doorway tucked in a back corner that nobody else around could even see unless they were looking for it. There's a little white patch on the stone wall that sticks out from its surroundings, and he merely walks up to it and presses his hand against it. A light flashes and he pulls away.

"BIOMETRIC DATA CONFIRMED. WELCOME, AGENT BROWN. YOUR UNIQUE IDENTIFIER FOR THIS VISIT IS: ONE-SIX-SEVEN-SIX-TWO-FOUR-ONE. THE NETWORK IS NOW ACTIVE."

A voice speaks up, reminding me of the one at the office where Master and I were attacked by that red haired woman. And to think, not an hour after she paralyzed us, Master is sending me off to live with her. I'm scared... what if she tries to hurt me? Master won't be here to protect me.

Will I have to hurt Marie, or will I have to kill her, as I did with Danis? I don't want to attack people... but Master says I should be ready. If he tells me to, I will. I'll do anything he tells me to do.

Ben pushes the door open and walks inside, beckoning for me to follow. When I step in, he closes the door, and there's a clicking sound. Did it lock? This is creepy...

The room is dark, but he reaches over and taps something on the wall, making a light turn on. Once the room is brighter, he points to a few round metal pads sitting on the floor. "This is where we part ways. This teleporter will take you directly to Marie's residence."

Teleporter? That's the same word Master uses to appear and disappear. It's the same as how the old man left, but he didn't have to say anything at all.

Somehow, these metal circles are very foreboding, but I just have to suck it up. Master will call me weak if I can't even do this much. I step on the pad gingerly and turn back to face the charcoal-skinned man. He mumbles something to himself, but I don't catch it.

Suddenly I'm not there anymore. Everything changes so fast I don't even notice for a few seconds. I'm standing inside a clean, white room now. Comfortable looking white chairs and a table are in the center, which reminds me of Yama's dining room... except these are much plainer looking. They're built to serve a purpose, not be pretty.

Paintings hang on the walls, but I don't know what the depictions and objects are in any of them. One painting is of a man wearing white robes, he's holding an apple, and he has wings coming from his back. Is he a bird? Mother told me about birds once, but I haven't seen them even though they're supposed to be on Earth. Birds have wings, and they probably eat apples.

...I've never tasted an apple before. I wonder if it's as good as peat-zuh? Master and I both like to eat peat-zuh. Does Marie eat it too?

"Oh. You're here." A voice speaks up from behind me, and I squeak slightly and turn around to face her, barely keeping my nerves together. This woman made Master fall to the ground, and she didn't even touch him. She must have powerful magic... Mother always warned me about how dangerous magic was.

"Nothing to say? Welcome to my home." Marie waves her hands around here and there, not caring about whether I'm impressed or not. "I had a room set up for you over here. Fresh clothes too, since you don't appear to have any of your own."

She stares at me expectantly, but I don't say anything. I never do. The only person I'd ever want to talk to... is...

"Saint Joseph, I figured you might be a little shy, but this is ridiculous. Not even a 'hello'?" Marie rolls her eyes and turns away. "Whatever. Here, you're probably hungry. Have a ration bar." She reaches into her pocket and pulls out a small colorful rectangle and throws it to me. Thanks to Master's training, I reach up and catch it without trying. My hand moves automatically and plucks it from the air, the 'rashun bar' moving far too slowly for me to miss it.

Marie's look of annoyance fades immediately when she sees this. "Oh? Those are excellent reflexes. He must have enhanced you. Hmm." She doesn't think about it long. "Come, have a seat. Let's get to know each other."

She and I sit at the table, though I feel a little worried. Am I allowed to sit here? It's so... nice. I didn't know tables and chairs could look so white. I bet in bright light they would be hard to look at.

Marie's gaze shifts from me, to the bar in my hands, and back to me. "Are you going to eat it?"

I nod slowly and stick it in my mouth and bit. A strange... *crinkly* feeling enters my mouth. I can't bite into it. It's soft, but covered in a layer of something tasteless.

"Gods. Are you an idiot? You have to take the wrapper off, first. Haven't you ever eaten a ration bar before?"

I shake my head slowly and pull it out to look at it. I now notice words written on it, black letters on a white background, but I can't read them. Master said he'd teach me to read someday... but I'm probably too stupid for that. I don't know anything.

I tug at the ends of the wrapper, even twist and pull at it, and after a few seconds, I get a little irritated and just rip it apart with my hands. The contents of the package explode and fly all over the room, and Marie's expression turns deathly still. I stare in horror at the mess I've made. She's going to hurt me, I can tell.

"Wow. You tore that wrapper to shreds. It's not like foil is made of anything especially sturdy, but this is still very interesting. Don't worry about the mess; I have droids to take care of that."

Marie taps a thingy on her wrist, and a moment later a wall panel slides open, and a nice looking man steps out, dressed in a suit that reminds me of Emperor Beelzebub. "Hello! I am here to serve! How may I assist you?"

"Clean this up. But before that, grab me another ration bar." She leans to the side and winks at me before pulling a little white stick from her shirt. "I'll show you how to open it... err... what was your name again?"

I don't respond, so she sighs and taps her fingers together. "Jason wasn't kidding. You are a silent one, after all. Ah, I recall now. Your name is Lora, right?"

I nod slowly at her. "Well, if a 'yes' or a 'no' are all I can get, I'll have to work with it. So, you lived among demons, is that also correct?"

Her voice lilts playfully as if it's just a casual question, but I feel as though it is the first of many. I nod along, and she pulls another item from her inner jacket, a little metal thing barely even a quarter the size of her hand. It looks like a tiny canteen. A moment later, she lifts the top of it up, and there's a spark of light followed by a clicking sound, and then a small flame appears at the top. To my amazement, she lights the little stick on fire and puts it into her mouth.

"I hope you don't mind if I smoke?"

I shake my head, and she leans back in her chair and blows gray smoke out of her mouth. Even ten feet away, on the other side of a long table, the smell is gross compared to the clean air in the room.

"Good. It's not like I'd care if you had said yes. At least you understand basic etiquette... as well as your place."

There's a long silence as she continues sucking and puffing on the little white stick. The man walks back up and hands her the 'rashun bar' she asked for. Marie is immediately annoyed. "It's not for me, stupid! It's for the guest!"

"Not a problem! Getting right to it!" He turns around, still smiling the whole time even after she called him stupid, and then he walks over and sets it in front of me on the table.

He continues to stand there, and I feel uncomfortable as he stares at me in total silence. Marie groans and pulls my attention away from him. "All *right*! You've done it! Now go clean up the floor! Use your fucking brain!"

"Absolutely! I am performing that task now!" He swivels away and walks into the kitchen, probably so he can grab cleaning supplies.

Marie shoves the stick in her mouth, stand up abruptly, and walks over to my side of the table. She grabs the bar up and points to one of the ends. "You have to tear this part off, see? Just peel and pull, then the bar comes out."

I nod along again, and she hands it to me. Without any trouble at all, I follow her instructions, and a lumpy brown rectangle pops out and lands on the table in front of me.

"Executives get the best ration bars. That one may even have traces of actual grain in it. Oats, if you're lucky. This one looks to be only about seventy percent reconditioned. Go ahead then, try it."

I don't know what 'recondishunned' is, but the look on her face tells me it's not going to be tasty. With my expectations set low, I bite into the bar and chew slowly. It tastes surprisingly good. Very chewy, with a sugary taste, like the 'soda pop' Master lets me drink when we eat peat-zuh.

Marie walks back over and sits down on her side of the table. "Wow, you seriously enjoy that, huh? You've never eaten a ration bar before, then. Lucky."

There's a moment where I look into her eyes and see something in there, something regretful.

As if to indicate my intuition is right, Marie sighs. "It wasn't always like this, you know, before we put in the population controls. I knew food was going to be a problem, but I didn't realize the energy limitations would be so severe."

I take another bite of my bar, nod, and pretend to understand what she's talking about. I have no idea though.

"Replicators just take too much energy. Can't waste it on food when there are more pressing concerns. Not that it's any of your business." She mashes the fire stick into a little tray on her side of the table. I hadn't noticed it before, due to the fact it's colored the same as the table it sits on. "A lot of things didn't work out the way I wanted. Human nature is so... finicky."

I finish off my bar and mimic her by setting the wrapper down on my side of the table, though much more gently.

She claps her hands together. "Alright. Now that you've had a nice little lunch, it's time for answers. You won't be able to tell me much yourself, so I'll have to get answers my way."

I shift a little in my seat at the way she said that. *What do you mean?* I want to ask... but I can't speak, even if I tried. I don't know what prevents me, but maybe someday I'll be able to get past it.

Marie stands up again and walks out of the room, only to return a minute later holding something metal that looks like a pen. I've seen pens before, in Yama's domain, but this one is a little bigger than the others that Emperor Beelzebub used.

Marie smiles pleasantly at me. "I'm going to poke your arm real quick. Can you take your armor off, please?"

I didn't expect her to be so nice all of a sudden. I smile back at her, though my smile is weaker, and then quickly pull the new armor Master gave me off after pressing the 'disengage' button. I start to pull my shirt off too, but Marie shakes her head. "That won't be necessary. Just let me see your arm super quick..."

Marie gently takes my arm and I feel a slight sting. She pokes me with a sharp stick of some sort, but the pain is gone almost instantly. "There we go, now I have your blood. Let's find out a little more about you, hm?"

Her smile slowly fades over the next several seconds as her wrist thing makes an image appear in midair, one I can't see. She stares at it silently, and soon her smile is completely gone.

"Oh. So you're Goldeshian. Fifteen percent, at that. So... that makes you a descendant of the filthy-" She pauses to take a little breath. "Well, we can't all help who our ancestors are. You're quite young though. Not a trace of genetic modifications in you. You're living a normal human lifespan, unaided by technology. How miserable. What is life if you can't live a long time, eh?"

She winks at me and then walks back over to her side of the table, this time just leaning against it as she taps some buttons in midair. "I'll just send this information to a subordinate of mine, and we'll see what he has to say about your history."

A minute passes, and I come to realize that she is simply staring into space. She isn't looking at her wrist image anymore, but past it to something else. I want to ask her what's on her mind, but she speaks up. "Goldesh III. A stain on my perfect society. All the work I put into this galactic empire, and some uppity fools thought they could question all the benefits I had given them. They failed to understand why we wouldn't just finish the demons off. We couldn't, and still can't, you know. Killing off the demons would have other side effects. You understand, right?"

She looks back at me, a sad expression on her face. I simply nod, even though I have no idea what she's talking about. Nothing she says makes any sense.

"...Right. It's not that simple. I have seen what happens every time humanity no longer has a designated threat. They have to find or create a new one. Who would it be? The Volgrim? The angels? Perhaps even themselves? I can't have that. Who cares if the food is a little stale and the entertainment is sanitized of imperfections? The path to perfection is fraught with peril. It's something my... sisters... they wouldn't understand."

I yawn audibly and catch myself, but she already noticed. "Oh, I'm boring you. As expected, nobody can keep up with my vast intellect." She scratches her neck thoughtfully. "You never really told me about yourself, but this blood might just be the key. Maybe I can figure out, once and for all, what happened to the *Phantoms of Goldesh III*."

She shrugs absentmindedly before quickly walking around the table and jerking me to my feet harshly. "Come on, then. Let's get you cleaned up. I won't have a filthy stinking pig in my house. You smell like a week's worth of sweat."

I follow along behind her as she heads for what I'm guessing is this place's form of a bathtub. The insults don't bother me. I've heard far, far worse. Mostly from men like Danis.

A shiver crawls down my spine at the thought of his name. I can never wash away the feeling of his breath on my face, or the pain of his knife on my back. The only thing Master has ever done that I have questioned is bringing Danis back to life. Why? I killed him. He deserved to die. Master even said so.

Master is smarter than me. Maybe he brought Danis back to show I don't have to be afraid anymore. Master will protect me. Even if he doesn't, I can protect myself. I don't have to be scared.

But... I still am.

Master will be so disappointed if he finds out.

"Have you ever taken a sonic shower before, young lady? We don't waste water here, so you'll have to learn to clean yourself properly."

She stares at me expectantly before gesturing to my clothes. " *Now* you take those off. Learn the proper time and place."

I nod at her and sigh as I pull my shirt off. I reach for my pants, but she stops me. "What the devil are those marks on your back? Did Jason do that to you?"

I shake my head, but she seems to get the wrong idea. "No wonder you won't talk. He must have you quite frightened. He must be worse than I thought. Well, in any case, let's get started, shall we?"

For a moment, I almost see a glint of something else in her eyes. Almost like a mischievous smile... but it vanishes instantly, and I assume it must have been my imagination.

I was wrong about Marie... she can be brash, but she's quite kindhearted. Marie is like the polar opposite of Master.

I still prefer him more, though.

Part 402b: Family Ties

A sharp beam of light pierces the solar screen outside and lands directly on my face, making me blink my eyes and raise an untrapped arm to shield my face. A computerized voice speaks from the ceiling, softly so as to not wake the other in the room. "Supreme Commander, it is the designated time for you to wake up."

I yawn reflexively and pull some hair out of my mouth as I smack my lips. It's Sarah's hair, not mine. She was so excited to see me that she dozed off on top of me after I plowed her for five hours straight. I feel like part of my soul has been sucked out of my body, along with other uncouth things. Her small, soft, supple form, coupled with her decisive sexual appetite and knowledge contrast dramatically with Lora's. Lora is taller, standing nearly half a head higher, and her body is made of iron thanks to the enhancements I've given her. As well, her past prevents her from fully enjoying sex.

But Sarah is something else. It's like the great gods of this universe engineered the perfect life form. I'm reminded of succubi, from myths of old. The perfect taste, the perfect size, and the perfect feeling... everything a man could want in a woman.

Funny, why do I think of succubi at a time like this? I feel more than a passing feeling of familiarity with the thought. Were there any in Yama's lair? They would be demonic entities, after all.

No. I never saw one.

I flinch slightly as a feeling of pain spreads inside my head. Sometimes I feel like I'm on the verge of something big, but it never pans out. Maybe I've contracted a permanent side effect of the cryosleep sickness. Perhaps I was in the icy containment unit for so much time it screwed up my head.

That's probably all it is.

The woman on top of me mumbles something and I feel a drop of liquid on my chest as she drools in her sleep. I don't mind. It feels good, being this close to a woman. Something about this position too... it feels familiar. Even Sarah herself evokes faint images of a false past. Christ, I'm probably going insane. Did the demons poison me somehow? Being around all those horrors must have messed up my head.

Gently, I roll over and pull Sarah to my side, kissing her hard as our lips meet. I simply can't get enough... she's intoxicating. I want to chew on her breasts all day long, spend the rest of my life with her.

This feeling is... unnatural.

I manage to tear myself away and breathe heavily as I lie on my back. There's a faint noise outside the bedroom, the sound of something rustling around, which makes my heart freeze. It's probably that goddamn demonic animal thing. What in the seven hells created it? Why would that other Jason have something like that roaming around his house? Self-defense? Maybe to protect Sarah? If the latter, I couldn't blame him. There isn't a woman alive comparable to her. If Sarah were to die, I feel like my heart would tear in half.

I sit up and spin carefully to sit on the edge of my bed. The thought of that black hound outside fills me with dread. Quietly, I whisper under my breath. "**Wear.**"

My invisible armor appears on my body and immediately I can breathe a little easier. The thought it would take that mutt some real effort to chew my insides to pieces is somehow comforting.

I stand up and yank my clothes to myself with telekinesis with a practiced movement. All the pieces fly on at once, and I levitate myself in the air to yank my pants onto my legs. If I had what I would call a signature power, a favorite technique, it would be telekinesis.

What about the other Jason? Did he have a preferred ability? Maybe super speed, strength, manipulating the minds of others...

No, even beyond him, what about other Wordsmiths? Didn't Yama say there were more of them? He told me there was an army of them. He claimed they were hunting me down and were going to kill me... yet they don't exist as far as I can see.

Did he lie to me? Have I been wrong, all along?

I understand the need to lie. Lying is one way a weak, frail race like the demons might be able to survive. Keeping slaves to use as sexual currency among the humans is likely just one way they have to maintain order. Demons are more cunning than I might have thought. No doubt they possess plenty of spiritual energy, and many abilities similar to mine, but against the might of humanity, those are trifles.

One thing is for sure. I *despise* weaklings.

Sarah rustles in the bed behind me as I start to walk to the door. "Jason? Where are you going, honey?"

I turn back to her and smile slightly. "Just to eat some food. Would you like anything?"

She rolls around on the bed, clutching the blankets to her chest for several seconds. Back and forth she rolls until she decides to sit up. "I do! I want three juicy steaks, a big bowl of

macaroni and cheese, a plate of smoked salmon, one head of lettuce, a glass of cold milk, and at least fifteen sugar cookies!"

Several long seconds pass as I stare at her giddy, childlike expression of glee. She's serious. "Uh. Okay. I'll get right on that."

I start to reach out with my mind to move the dresser I blocked the door with, but she pipes up again. "Oh! We forgot to pray last night! We have to pray before the meal in that case!"

"Huh? Pray? Why?" I turn to raise an eyebrow at her, and she flops back on the bed. "Duh, silly! It's the law! Jeez, you're so forgetful sometimes. I'll have to ask Marie to take it a little easier on you at the office."

"Oh. The law. I see." I scratch my head at the thought of prayer being mandatory. I'm not a particularly religious person, especially not after finding out demons are real and that angels exist. The whole point of prayer is faith, right? It doesn't take faith to pray to something you know exists.

The dresser heaves away from the door with the power of my mind, and I swallow as I press the unlock button. The door slides up, and I spare a peek around the corner. The massive black hound isn't anywhere to be seen. I carefully walk through the door, keeping my pace slow, and a voice speaks out in the room. "Oh. Supreme Commander. I didn't know you were back from your trip already."

A young boy, about twelve years old, sits at a table, chewing on something that reminds me of a granola bar. He has long blonde hair and blue eyes, just like Sarah and I both. "Who are you?"

He pauses mid-bite and stares at me with a slight confusion on his face, though somehow the regal manner in which he sits belies a certain maturity for his age. "Are you testing me?"

I clear my throat and stand up straight. He seems to regard me with a certain level of awe, so it's best not to disrupt that image. "Yes. State your name and our relationship."

Even as he speaks, I feel the memories of him begin to enter my mind. "Sorry, sir. I am Timothy Hiro, your 130th child, the youngest of your bloodline."

I groan inwardly. He's my son, and I just acted like I didn't even know him. This whole 'taking the other Jason's place' is harder than I thought. "Excellent. I'm glad you remember your place."

I calmly continue walking past to the kitchen counter, and just as I'm about to wordsmith some food, Sarah appears at the doorway. Her carefree smile evaporates as she spots Timothy. "W-what are you doing here? You're supposed to be with-"

He stands up quickly, a similar expression on his face. "I apologize, mother. I did not realize father was home. The dormitories are unavailable for a week due to renovations. I assumed father would not be home, so I thought it would be okay if I stayed here for a while." He flinches reflexively and shoots an odd look at me. "Sorry, sir. I didn't mean anything by that."

Huh? What the hell is this kid talking about? "You didn't mean anything by... *what?*"

He gazes at me silently for a few moments, then lowers his eyes. "I didn't mean to refer to you as 'father'. I know how you don't like that."

A long, uncomfortable silence fills the entire room as everyone stares silently at each other. Finally, I groan loudly. "You may call me 'father'. I don't particularly mind."

"Huh?" Sarah stares at me in disbelief. "What? But- I thought- when did you decide this?"

I shrug and speak a word to the air. " **Food.** " In front of me, a series of plates appear, holding all the foods Sarah had asked for in the bedroom a minute before. "I decided just now. Is that a problem?"

Timothy raises his head up again, but this time, not to look at me... but at the food I created. "How did you do that?"

Sarah stares at me in wide-eyed disbelief. "You just... wordsmithed in front of your son..."

"Wordsmithed?" Timothy turns to his mother. "What is that? It looked like magic- like what the demons use."

Goddammit. Things are going from one to one hundred rapidly.

Still, it won't do to get distressed now. I need to play it cool. I keep my gaze even as I look between the two of them. "I've never really been there for you, have I, Timothy?"

His lip trembles slightly. "Uh... I mean..."

"I've been a terrible father. I see that now." My simple words resonate in the air as both of them glance at each other and back to me. "I went into the labyrinth and saw some disturbing things. Those things are not fit for a conversation among friends or family, so I will spare you both the details. Nevertheless, they shook me to my core."

Sarah nods slowly. "You *have* been acting strange, sweetheart. I didn't realize that... that you'd gone through so much."

I nod sagely and make a show of closing my eyes as if I'm in pain. "I'm sorry, to both of you. I need to be a better man."

"N-no, you're fine just the way you are, sir." Timothy carefully takes another bite of the granola bar in his hand. "I'm just... confused. I didn't realize you could use... magic..." He

glances at Sarah and she smiles at him pleasantly. Underneath her smile though, I feel a sense of hostility. Something akin to *stop asking so many questions of your father*, but it might just be me.

"Your father has always had these abilities. He and I made a family decision not to let our children know, though. The fewer people who knew, the fewer chances there would be for political enemies to use us against him."

"Oh." Timothy nods. "So not even my elder brothers and sisters know?"

"Not even one." Sarah swallows hard and shoots me a questioning look. I honestly have no idea if it's true, but I wink at her in the affirmative. She glides over and sits down at the table, next to Timothy and touches his hand. "Well, if your father is okay with it, you can stay here until the dorms open again. However, you must agree not to let his secret leave beyond the three of us."

Before Timothy can nod, I pick up two plates of food and walk over to the table, setting both of them in front of Sarah. "I could also erase his memory, you know."

"Yes, you can. You probably should, too." She ignores the food and continues to stare at me as I turn and walk back to grab the rest of her meal.

Timothy clears his throat. "If you must, I understand, sir."

"Stop calling me 'sir'. I don't like it anymore." I set the food down and cut a piece of Sarah's steak off for myself to try it out. The flavor is quite sublime, and the texture is soft and juicy. Just the way I prefer it.

"O-okay. What should I call you then?" Timothy shifts nervously in his seat and grips the remainder of his food bar tighter.

"Just call me 'father'. That will do."

He swallows audibly. "Yes, father. Th-thank you."

I smile pleasantly at him, which only seems to disturb him more. He acts like he's never seen his dad smile, not even once. "There's no reason to be tense. I'm going to do a better job raising you, from now on. Certainly, more than I ever did before. I'm not going to erase your memory either. I am willing to trust my own son, after all."

Sarah smiles abruptly, having taken the situation in stride. "That's why I love you so much, Jason! You're always full of surprises!"

I can't tell if she's pulling my leg. Every time I get a hint of the previous Jason's life, he comes off as a stiff workaholic, and a devout pacifist... assuming Marie's description of his past is accurate. Describing him as being '*full of surprises*' is the opposite of what I'd imagine.

As the three of us finish off our food, with me making extra for myself and Timothy, the feeling around the table gradually becomes a little more relaxed, and Timothy even tries to smile as well. He's terrible at it, just like myself, but I have to appreciate him trying. This must be quite the odd experience for him. His father, whom he apparently rarely spoke with, has transformed from a soulless, heartless robot, into someone with a genuine personality.

Gods... I'm doing these two a favor by replacing the previous Jason. I'd kill myself if I ended up as lifeless and empty as he must have been. He wasn't just a weakling, but a terrible parent with no redeeming attributes.

I finish off a cup of orange juice and dab my mouth with a napkin. "Oh... by the way, I've been wondering where that demonic animal has gone."

Timothy tilts his head toward a door. "I don't like him very much, so I usually put him in the other room when I'm here." His face pales immediately after he says this. "I-I mean, if you want, I can release him, father. I didn't realize you would be home, and I was only thinking of myself. I'll just go and-"

"No!! I mean, no, that is fine. Just leave Fido in there. I'm not angry at all, Timothy." A bead of sweat trickles down my back at the realization I just averted a heart attack. At the least, this kid and I are remarkably similar to each other when it comes to that damn dog.

Sarah looks miffed at me. "His name is *Skippy*, Jason. Seriously... you named him."

I did? Jesus Christ, the other Jason was a major stupid-ass. I'd rather name that animal Lucifer-Fucker or something. "I know, I'm just joking... *honey*." I spit the pet name out and cringe inwardly. I should just avoid those and let other people use them. They don't suit me at all.

She giggles as if I just said the funniest thing in the world. "Oh, you! You've never been one to have a sense of humor! I like these new changes, it's getting me all hot and bothered."

Timothy shifts in his seat. "Mother..."

"Right, right, sorry! You're still a child, not even two-hundred years old! I can't be talking like that in front of you. I'm such a pervert!"

I spare a glance at Timothy's face. He's almost two hundred years old? Good grief, he's nearly ten times older than me, his so-called 'father'. It's tough to consider giving out fatherly advice to an old man. The only thing old about me is my physical appearance, since I'm deliberately disguising myself as the other Jason.

I clean up the table with my levitation after I'm done, and then get up from my seat. "Alright, Sarah. I'm off. I have a meeting with the local military generals today."

She jumps up and hugs me, rubbing her blessed body against mine excitedly. "Ohhh, do you *have* to go? Why not take a day off and stay with me?"

"I'd love to, but this is already scheduled. I have to keep up appearances. You know how it is."

She pulls back and gives me a perplexed look. "Nope, no clue! Anyway, we need to pray before you go. It's the law."

Timothy looks up from his chair, startled. "Oh! I forgot last night! I'll join in!"

"Tsk ts. Like father, like son!" Sarah pulls me back to the table and joins hands with Timothy. All of us sit down and bow our heads, but nobody says anything. I start to feel a little weirded out, but she raises her head back up. "Okay! I gave my energy to Zeus, like usual."

"I as well." Timothy pulls away from her and looks at me.

"I did too." I lie without hesitation. I have no idea what they're talking about, but it's easy enough to play along.

Timothy and Sarah both yawn at the same time. Sarah speaks as soon as she's finished. "Oh man, that took a lot out of me. I'm gonna nap for a while. Have a good day at work!"

She leans over and kisses me on the cheek playfully before getting up and heading to her room. I, in turn, stand and walk to the doorway. "I'll see you tonight, Sarah."

She pauses before entering the room. "Oh, sorry. I'm going over to Marcus Atkins place this evening. I won't be back until the day after, but I'll see you then!"

Huh? Marcus Atkins? Another man?

I decide to ignore that for the moment. I have more pressing concerns. "Right... see you later, then."

Unceremoniously, I wave to Timothy and head out the door. He waves back timidly as well. "Goodbye... father."

Those two words must have taken more courage than even my decision to kill Gressil... when all of this began.

"You too, kid."

* * *

This universe is strange. Foreign. Everything is upside down. The more I learn, the more questions I have to ask. Why the hell would prayer be mandatory, enshrined in the law? Does it help combat the demons or something?

I've hardly asked the question in my mind when the answer appears in the form of one of Supreme Commander Jason's memories.

Prayer gives energy to the angels and gods, who require it to live. This, in turn, forges an unbreakable alliance. Humans do not require this energy for any reason, and thus we can give ours freely. In return, they offer us a one-time life insurance policy: the ability to be reborn as angels if we should die. However, this is shameful. Only a fool would die after being given effective immortality.

Ah, I see. I don't understand how that resurrection system works, but that is a fair trade-off. I should go and visit the angels soon, and see how their society functions, as well as what it looks like.

I move from place to place, taking my time and absorbing the sights as I glance down at the pad in my hand. It's the most advanced piece of electronics I've ever seen in my life, yet the memories the old Jason has of it are littered with words like *outdated* and *obsolete*. There are gadgets of far higher technological superiority than even this in existence, and I can't begin to fathom how they might work.

I pause after entering an open area with a glass floor, a large round pod-like building that connects the megascraper I live in to the Stratoscraper I work at. This large intermediary is held up by a long, thin pole that extends up from the planet's surface two miles below. Such a sturdy pole could not be made in the world I came from, but here it is just one of many unbelievable things that allow this world to thrive.

As I walk, I glance down below at what is presumably the planet's surface. The transparent floor allows me to see a thick cloud-like formation of mist, but unlike the white clouds I saw when I was growing up, these are brown, as if someone had stained the clouds with thick paint. I cannot see the ground at all. There are numerous smaller buildings visible in between skyscrapers, megascrapers, and stratoscrapers, but all of the smaller buildings extend only a little above the clouds. Most are barely even visible.

Smog. The word pops into my head and I stare with a feeling of melancholy. In the end, humanity ruined the Earth. We exploited it to hell and back, and now we live in these massive buildings not out of luxury, but necessity.

I pull my datapad up to look at it. Something catches my eye that I hadn't noticed before. The ambient temperature around me is a perfect twenty-one degrees Celsius, but the temperature outside is listed as... fifty-five degrees? Good god, the greenhouse effect must be in full swing. The sun doesn't appear any brighter in the sky, so I doubt it's that.

I continue walking through the center building and eventually arrive in the stratoscraper that leads to my office, and other military facilities. As my memories arrive one by one, pieces fall into place. In addition to the diplomacy venues, my office, the Engineering Corps, and other such facilities, this building also is a place where four hundred million humans show up to work every single day. I wonder what sort of tasks they have to complete? There were never enough jobs in the time I came from, so with all of the automation on display, either unemployment has been eradicated, or something shifted fundamentally in society to allow so many jobs to exist.

I head toward an elevator, and a chill goes down my spine as a voice speaks from a dark corner off to the side. "There you are, Jason Hiro." Yama steps slightly from the darkness to look at me, though he stays tucked away where the light can't reach him.

"Yama? What are you doing here? Aren't you in danger walking among humans?" I step toward him and glance around hesitantly. "There are a lot of cameras and people around here... this is a foolish move just to see me. You're going to get both of us caught."

"Unlikely. This is where I meet all of my informants. It is just off the beaten path, and this hover-shaft services only elites in the upper levels. In any case, I am in contact with many of them already."

"I see. Still, why are you bothering me? I wasn't expecting to run into you."

He holds his hand forward, and I spot a familiar black orb at once. "You left behind your source of power. Blaarjiim can give answers to many questions I am certain you have."

"Oh. Right." I quickly step forward and pluck the black orb from his hands, then stare at it uneasily. "This thing is the size of a softball. How am I supposed to hide it?"

Blaarjiim's ancient face appears in my mind. "Your wordsmithing is the source of many abilities that you have yet to discover. Simply speak the word 'storage' and I can be hidden there and pulled out whenever you wish. However, this has the downside that I will be cut off from the physical realm and left all alone... so I would prefer you not do this unless necessary."

"Huh. That's an option, I suppose." I scratch my chin and look down at Yama. "I have a question though since you're here. It's in regards to the Supreme Commander whose place I took."

He folds his arms together and stares at me. "Go on."

"You said that there were hundreds, even thousands of other Wordsmiths that could kill me, yet the Supreme Commander knew of only himself and I. Did you lie to me?"

He nods. "I did. However, in a way, I did not."

"I don't understand."

"Neither do I." Yama hisses and looks to my side as if deep in thought. "I know that other Wordsmiths exist. I have seen them. I am certain Marie knows of their existence as well. In my spying, I have seen them come and go, yet from where they hail, I am not sure."

"So they do exist? You're cryptic." I growl in irritation. "Why can't you just be honest with me? I understand why you might lie, but it isn't an endearing quality or one that builds a positive alliance up. Rather, it will tear down any trust we could have."

Yama sneers at me and leans back against the wall. "You play with words that hold no meaning. I trust you as little as you trust me. It is for the foolish. I have placed a nugget of hope that you might be useful to me one day, but I know you might turn your personal prejudice against me as well. It is a risky gamble, but one that I am willing to take."

Blaarjiim smiles in the back of my brain. "Humans consolidate their power and use their numerical and technological superiority to crush demonkind, while demons bicker and squabble among each other for the rights to rule increasingly smaller plots of land. It is apparent that one of these two is going to win this war while the other loses. Yama, you would do well to speak the truth in front of this human. You've foolishly given him the chance to destroy you if he wishes."

I pat the orb lovingly with my free hand. "That's the spirit, Blaarjiim. Yama, he's correct. I don't like it when people aren't straight with me. A little honesty would help our relationship mature."

Yama's smirk fades away, and he glares at me listlessly. "If you think the demons are full of lies, you have yet to meet the rest of your kind. The best way I have found to ensure the safety of my species is by harnessing the greed of yours. You will soon find this out, one way or another. I seek only one thing; to return demons to their former numbers and to rebuild our kind to their former glory. I do not seek the destruction of humanity, merely the sovereignty of my own. Is that too much to ask for, human?"

I sigh and stare at Blaarjiim for several seconds. "Not really, I suppose. I can understand, and even respect that ideal."

"Most excellent. Then we see eye to eye on this issue."

The demon smiles cunningly at me, and I resist the urge to quip. *Eye to eye? But I'm six-feet tall, and you're just under four!*

Yeah, that would be slightly disrespectful. "We do. In any case, I have a meeting to attend to. Thank you for the... present."

An idea pops into my head from seemingly nowhere. "Oh, Blaarjiim, are you capable of being silent when out in the open? No speaking at all, not even to me in my mind."

"I am."

Great. That makes this easy for me. I quickly wordsmith a sling that wraps over my shoulder and loops down to my waist. I then set Blaarjiim inside of it. " **Invisible.** "

The sling and his orb both vanish from view. Yama smiles creepily at me. "An inventive solution, as expected. However, Marie has energy sensors everywhere. They may pick him up if you pass inside their range. This area is a blind spot, so it's fine for now."

"I understand. In that case, what if..." I aim my mind at Blaarjiim's now-invisible orb. " **Suppress.** "

Yama tosses his hands in the air. "I can no longer sense him. You'd best hope you don't drop his orb, or you're unlikely to find it."

"I wouldn't say that. **Summon.** " With a single word, his invisible orb disappears from the sling and reappears in my hand.

Yama gapes at me for a moment for regaining his composure. "You have this under control. I will be going, then."

I nod and turn to walk toward the hover-shaft. "And I as well. Thank you for bringing Blaarjiim to me, Yama."

Yama doesn't reply, and instead makes a sign with his hands. He vanishes, and I'm left standing by my lonesome.

"The Second Emperor is a formidable demon, you know. Even so, he is worried about what your appearance will do to human society, for the good or the bad." Blaarjiim chuckles softly. "Heh... I warned Yama once... he had stabilized the situation. Throwing a wrench in the machine is a terrible choice. The humans lack the diplomatic votes needed to exterminate the demons, and the previous Supreme Commander was a sympathetic man to the demon's cause. He didn't wish to eliminate them, albeit less because he liked demons, and more because of what would happen after."

"After?"

"If humanity has no enemy, they will invent a new one. It's as simple as that."

"Cheh. Life is boring without conflict. Rainbows and bunnies are not what I live for." I step into the hover-shaft and press the button which will take me to the conference floor.

"What is a 'bunny'?"

Blaarjiim's confused expression makes me almost laugh. "It's nothing. Just an animal humanity has probably exterminated."

The bastards.

Part 403b: The Dark Descent

The hover-shaft continues to take me up, and to my relief, nobody gets aboard with me. This particular shaft stops about fifty floors before the top of the stratoscraper, and those floors are usually reserved for crop engineering and other such things. I learned this thanks to my trusty datapad, which never back-talks me or gives me lip. Ask a question, get an answer. I like that.

The hover-shaft door hisses open, and I'm greeted by two familiar faces. Lora and Marie are standing just off to the side, waiting for my arrival. Lora is wearing a formal uniform, one that resembles what everyone else in this massive building wears to work. It's orange, with black all over the edges and stitching, two big buttons at the belly and breast to close up the outer coat, and a gaudy looking oversized collar that splays out to the left and right several inches on each side. Still, I've seen so many people wearing these uniforms that I've grown used to the design.

Lora yawns and smiles when she sees me. Even Marie looks a little haggard. "Did you two even sleep last night?"

Marie shakes her head. "Barely. This girl is so uneducated about the proper policies of the United Earth Forces that she would be an outright embarrassment to you and me if she were to represent either one of us. What are you going to do with her, anyway? You may not know how things work around here, but at least you have a modicum of sense regarding modern society. Lora is foreign to everything about modern living."

I pull Lora a little closer, and away from Marie. "She's just a silent bodyguard. She doesn't need to be a tactical genius or anything, and I don't expect her to be. As far as customs, she will learn those in time."

The three of us start walking down the halls, and I nod at people who walk past, saluting Marie and I. Marie lights up another cigarette and coughs as she inhales deeply. "That doesn't change the fact that you, especially, have no idea about the current state of the galaxy. If you're going to stand in as a proxy for Jason 12F, I'll need to debrief you on everything occurring in the universe, and that will take a while."

"Hmm." I shoot a glance at Marie slyly. "By the way, I am curious... how many wordsmiths are there in the galaxy? Are we quite common?"

"Not even close. You and 12F are the only ones that existed, and now it's just you."

"Then why do you keep calling him '12F'? Did you think that designation slipped past me? It almost sounds like he's a clone, or part of a freak science experiment."

Marie pauses walking and turns to stare at me with a bored expression on her face, as if this doesn't matter to her at all. "It's the designation of the building he lives in. I live in the same building as he did, and thus you, so that's why my designation is Marie 12F. It's a way for humanity to refer to clusters of humans all at once."

"I don't believe you."

"You can think whatever you like."

She turns back around and continues walking, but now my suspicions are burning up. What she said doesn't even make sense.

"Marie, you explicitly stated that I killed a 'fellow Jason'. That implies there are more like me, and probably clones or something. Do you think I'm an idiot?"

She coughs after taking another puff on her cigarette. "You copied 12F's memories. If I were lying, you should be able to tell. Did he know of any other Jasons?"

I scratch my neck and look at Lora. She shakes her head and turns away. Of course she wouldn't know anything. This conversation should have brought some of the Supreme Commander's memories back to me, but it didn't. If he did know of any other Jasons, mentioning them would have triggered a flashback.

"He didn't. Then again, he also didn't know you called him 'Jason 12F', so that designation might have been a secret."

We round a corner and Marie sends a vicious expression my way. "We're almost there. Keep quiet and let me do all the talking today. You're liable to start a diplomatic nightmare if you shoot off your mouth without thinking."

She ignored my question. Of course she did. That's acceptable; I knew she wouldn't be so forthcoming. She has her secrets, and I have my own. I know where I hid the previous Supreme Commander, after all..

I nod at her words and pretend to accept her orders, but I know this alliance will not last. She's dangerous. I can only hope she hasn't poisoned Lora's mind, or I'll have to get rid of her, too.

We arrive outside the doorway into the conference room, and I turn to Lora. "Stay outside, just stand here at the door. We'll be out soon."

Marie chuckles. "These meetings can take up to five hours. Don't force the girl to stand the whole time."

"She can handle it."

Lora sighs quietly and pulls off to the side, leaning against the door. Marie strides into the room brazenly, as if she owns the place. I walk behind her and stand up a little straighter, and everyone in the room stands up in their seats. "All rise! The Supreme Commander has entered!"

I walk over and sit down, and the two men to either side hold their hands forward. I reach over and shake, out of some preconditioned reflex. I don't know who they are, but my mind fills in their names after a second of me staring blankly. "Uh, Feldmann, Morlis, good to see both of you."

A few other people look miffed, and I realize I was supposed to shake their hands too. Oh well, a Supreme Commander can have off days, in my opinion.

I gaze around the table slowly, taking everything in. The first thing that immediately stands out to me is a man much further toward the end, wearing all white robes. His body glows slightly, and the people on each side have pulled away slightly, either to give him room or due to reverence. I can't tell which. His name appears in my mind, though.

Zeus.

The king of the gods, ruler of the angels. He exists, and so does heaven. Sometimes I wonder if I'm not still inside the cryopod, suffering under a brain melting delusion. Everything seems so fantastical, and yet here I am.

Zeus has a commanding presence, and people noticeably shrink back as his eyes sweep the room. Everyone he looks at seems noticeably disturbed as if they know he can see the sins they have committed, and he is judging them to Heaven or Hell as a result. His 8-foot frame makes him even more intimidating than I am, and he seems to suck some of the executive power from my title, *Supreme Commander*, with his, *King of Gods*.

Despite this, he seems quite amiable, and he smiles around at everyone before looking at me. "Commander Hiro! A pleasure to see you once again. I hope you don't mind me dropping in, today. I heard you had taken a personal trip into the labyrinth, so I wanted to hear your thoughts on the matter."

"Mmm. Yes." Marie takes a seat directly opposite me at the other end of the long table and shakes her head slowly. *Watch your words*. I don't have to use my telepathy to read that expression. "My trip into the Labyrinth was a little eye opening, I must admit."

A man beside stares at me with an odd expression. "You have seemed a little different since you came back from the labyrinth, or so I've heard." I scan his face quickly and his name pops up in my mind. Steven Feldmann, a mid-ranking officer but one the original Supreme Commander regarded with a lot of hope. In fact, there's even a little bit of personal sentiment thrown in there.

"I saw some things I would rather not talk about." My words make a few people at the table lean forward in interest. "Though I assure you, I will have to at some point. That day is not today."

"Understood." Zeus smooths his long, curled golden beard and regards me with the eye of a deity looking down upon a mere human. He doesn't seem to know about my Wordsmithing, or if he does, he hides it well. "I had hoped we could discuss that arrangement I spoke to you about before."

I haven't a clue what he's talking about. I glance at Marie, and she shrugs slightly. Whatever the discussion was, it was private. "Perhaps later, King Zeus."

"I look forward to your response." Zeus leans back in his chair, and Feldmann takes the lull in discussion to bring up something about blockades in the fifteenth dilithium mining sector or something. I don't know what he's talking about and it goes over my head.

I casually eyeball everyone at the table, and to my disgust I spot Danis, the psychopath whom I revived from the dead, of all the people, sitting here at the table staring ahead stonily. The poor fool hasn't even a drop of emotion on his face, and a few individuals sitting opposite him steal glances at his zombified expression every now and again and seem to mutter under their breaths this and that. Admittedly, I could not have punished him any worse than by forcing him to continue living as a soulless puppet. Yama wasn't lying about him, at least. For Danis to be sitting here at this table, he must be quite the high ranking citizen.

People chatter back and forth for a few minutes, and finally, Steven Feldmann turns to me and smiles casually... perhaps *too* casually. "So now that you're back from the Labyrinth, have you decided it's time to wipe them out?"

"I'm still debating it."

My response is straightforward, but a hush goes over the table as everyone turns to look at me in surprise.

"R-really, Commander Hiro? I had heard you were acting odd lately, but this... what did you see to make you undergo such a change of heart?" Feldmann gawks at me and others nod along to his question, so I shrug in response, even as Marie almost imperceptibly glares fire at me and shakes her head.

"I'm just considering it. I didn't say I was going to authorize anything."

A wiry looking Chinese man higher up the table and to my right throws his hands up in the air. "A cataclysm must be happening, and I missed it! The Supreme Commander is considering

a total extermination of the demonic forces! Am I still dreaming, or are fantasies becoming a reality?"

General Zhao. He's revered in the mind of the previous Jason. His sarcasm and lack of subtlety means he comes off as something of a crass oaf, but he has led thousands of incursions into demonic territory. From the bits and pieces of memory I can pull about him, he's been frustrated for a very long time, especially compared to my idea of what a 'long time' consists of... and it's because he hasn't been able to fight the Demons for hundreds, if not thousands of years.

Hmm. For some reason, the previous Jason, and apparently Marie as well, don't want to finish them off. Plenty of reasons why come to mind, but those wouldn't be enough to please someone like Zhao. No, he's a man who has lived through conflict, violence, and war. He loves killing demons, and the scars on his face attest to that. One especially brutal looking scar cuts across his right eye and all the way across the bridge of his nose. It's barely even visible, a sign of how old it is, but it shows that he keeps it to demonstrate his ferocity to anyone who wishes to see. In the age of significant medical advances that created what surely exists today, it's unthinkable that he couldn't have a perfect looking face.

I bet he gets a lot of women.

"You're not dreaming Zhao, but once again, I have decided nothing. Let's not get ahead of ourselves here. I would need to consider tactical options before ordering anything of the sort."

His sardonic smiles vanishes and his jaw slackens slightly. "Are all options on the table? Do I have the authority to eliminate demonkind?"

Marie quickly butts in before I can say anything else. "He isn't, General. Don't get ahead of yourself. We all know the demons are a filthy, violent race, but that doesn't mean we can just exterminate them. Killing off the demons can have unintended consequences to the balance of power in the galaxy."

Feldmann leans back in his chair and mutters something under his breath. All I can hear is something about 'political favors'.

General Zhao scowls at Marie. "Oh, yes, thank you for giving us your opinion, *Head Engineer*. I had forgotten you knew so much about military matters. I'll be sure and consult you in the future."

A woman with beautiful flowing brown hair speaks up loudly, berating him harshly. "Zhao, that's enough! There is no need to disrespect Mrs. Becker. Without her genius, we would never have been able to progress so rapidly during the Galactic Cold War of the early generations. Humanity has gained much, thanks to her contributions. Show respect."

Zhao stares at the woman but doesn't offer a retort. "As you wish." He slumps back in his seat and glares forward at nobody in particular.

Several moments of silence pass before Feldmann speaks up tentatively and manages to get the meeting back on track. While he speaks, I conceal a knowing smile. *Marie is not respected among the people here. She acts haughty, but she seems rather unimportant in the grand scheme of things.*

I had assumed she was a key player in the operations of Earth and the rest of humanity, but perhaps I overestimated her reach. Maybe her real power is merely using the previous Supreme Commander to lead her agenda. That would explain why she is so desperate to turn me into a political pawn; a puppet to do her bidding. She regards me in the same way as I do Danis; a useful tool that can be disposed of readily.

But if that's the case, she has much to learn. I'm only getting started. Once I have my bearings about me, and I can understand the situation, I will cease to be a passive follower, and will begin taking charge. I'll be damned if I let others control me, the most powerful god ever to walk the galaxy. Well, I'm not powerful yet, but I will be.

I stare at Zeus carefully and wonder to myself a great many things... but especially, *how much power would I gain if I drained his energy?* The commandos gave me a pittance, but Zeus is overflowing with the stuff.

I flinch as Feldmann pounds his side of the table with a gavel. "That is all for today, everyone. We will meet again next week to discuss other matters."

Oh. I thought the meeting would take hours, but this one only took half an hour or so. I was getting a little bored by these proceedings anyway.

I stand up and glance over at Zeus, intending to go and speak with him, but a tug at my side grabs my attention. Everyone else is already standing up and chatting with each other about menial things, but from the corner of my eye I spot Danis walking toward me- no, ah, past me and out the door. What use does a puppet have for conversations, I suppose?

Another tug at my side and I sigh and look to see who it is. It's Feldmann, and he scratches the back of his neck and stares at me with a look of concern. "Supreme Commander- err, that is, father... are you certain you've been feeling well? You said you went through something in the labyrinth, but I was just curious as to what. I will keep the matter private, if you wish."

"Huh? Father?" I pause for a moment to re-evaluate his words and then I remember. "Oh, right. It's nothing, really. I'm fine, thank you."

There's an odd moment shared between us as he looks at me oddly. I sigh inwardly. He's probably shocked I forgot he was my son. To be fair, I would be too. Not my fault the other Jason had fifty thousand kids.

I don't know what to say to him, and as I start to pull away awkwardly, the door hisses open. There's a *squeak* outside, as if a woman is gasping in fright, then the unmistakable sound of a violent impact, followed by something heavy smashing against a wall.

I turn to look, and my eyes widen in horror as I spot Lora, her arms outstretched with both palms aimed forward, and Danis, lying in a rapidly increasing pool of blood, his body broken and twisted against a badly fragmented marble wall. Everything clicks into place in my mind all at once. I should have warned Lora about him, but I forgot to do so. Shit, this is bad.

Her hands shake, and her breathing increases as she appears to start suffering a panic attack. I pull away from Feldmann and run to her, gawking at Danis's body and her outstretched palms. "Lora! Did you just- damn it, how could you do this?"

She stares at me, terror in her eyes. Danis must have startled her when she saw him, and she shoved him away with her Herculean strength. Her power probably killed him the instant he hit the wall. Under normal circumstances, I could clean up the blood, remove the body, and re-clone him, but with all these witnesses, there isn't a chance. Worse, it's almost definitely been captured on a camera, so there's no way to hide the evidence.

Feldmann rushes up behind me. "Good god! She killed Admiral Danis!"

"What? Someone killed Danis?" A man from the previous room speaks up curiously, and in an instant the entire room is filled with concern as people shuffle forward to see what's going on, oblivious to the fact that if this were a hit job by a professional assassin, their lives might be in danger too. Humans are always stupid.

Not ten seconds later, a squad of hypersuit-wearing guards comes running down the hall and aim their guns at Lora. "Halt! You are under arrest! Don't make a move!"

Lora turns to look at me, fear in her eyes. *I didn't mean to do it!* She doesn't have to say anything, the expression on her face says it all.

"You may not have meant to do this, but you did. I'll try and clean your mess up. You just behave yourself for a bit."

Marie shoves her way through the crowd of onlookers and arrives at my side. Her advanced mind takes in the scene and processes everything in an instant. "Stupid girl. We'll have to take care of this later."

"She didn't do it on purpose."

"I'm aware, *Commander*. This girl is far too innocent for that. I'll have a talk with you later."

Lora recoils as the commandos come for her, but I jab her in the ribs with a finger harshly. "Don't resist. Let them take you away. We'll deal with this ourselves. You need to reflect on this failure."

Her shoulders slump, and she nods, allowing the commandos to put a strange collar around her neck before leading her away, down the hall.

"What's with the collar?" I whisper to Marie so the others can't hear.

"A pacification choker. I invented it myself. Suitable for neutralizing prisoners and rowdy miners."

Miners? I want to ask but decide against it. I already understand what its purpose is.

As I watch them take away Lora, the human I've been closest to since arriving, Steven Feldmann walks up beside me. "Who is she? That must have been one hell of a punch."

"She *was* my bodyguard. I'll find out what happened later."

He recoils in disgust as he looks down at Danis's body. "I know you and Danis were close. The two of you would always chat after meetings. I'm sorry this had to happen. Even so, can't say I'll miss him."

I smirk just as Steven looks up. "I was never friends with that piece of filth. He was a savage, disgusting predator. In the end, he got what was coming to him." I nudge away one of Danis's hands with my boot. "Turns out you can't dodge death twice."

"Huh?" Steven looks at me questioningly, but I walk away from him.

"Nothing. You wouldn't understand."

* * *

Amy sits on her bed and sighs as she stares around at her barren apartment. Only a dresser with a few articles of clothing, a few nutrition bars for the morning, and a portable purifier for water sit on top. The rest of the room is vacant, just like the hole in her heart.

This is the last night I spend here, then. Took them an entire month, but it's official now. I'm no longer an upper-class citizen.

She wipes at her eyes, though no tears are forthcoming.

I just wanted to stop that demon. Why can't they bend the rules? Why did my entire squad have to be punished?

Her tears won't fall, though she wishes they could. She's killed too many people, so crying isn't becoming for one like her.

She finally raises her head to the wall, as the sun shines in through the window just barely lighting the room. It'll be night-time soon.

Just have to suck up my pride. Either I take a blow to my ego, or I live in the Lower-class district for the rest of eternity. I can't possibly choose that life.

"Jacob. Call my daughter. Call Sarah Gutierrez."

The computer in her room beeps. "There is no Sarah Gutierrez in your registered contact list. However, I do have 125,043 other possible listings for that name."

"Right... sorry. She changed her name. Of course she did. Her name is Sarah Hiro now. Just... call her, okay?"

"You have one name in your contact listings. The last time you dialed this number was three hundred sixteen thousand, nine hundred and fourteen years ago, seven months, six days-"

"Yes! Just dial the number, for god's sake."

The computer silently fills her request. A pleasant beeping tone fills the room, and thirty seconds pass. Just as Amy is about to hang up, a sweet sounding voice answers. "Hello! Who is this?"

A young woman's face appears on screen, her long blonde hair being unkempt as if she had just gotten out of bed. The bathrobe she is wearing merely adds to that theory in Sarah's mind, and a man is sleeping with her on the bed, but Amy can't tell who he is from this angle.

"Oh... Sarah, sweetheart. It's me. Your mother."

Sarah's cute smile fades away. "Huh? Mother?"

"Yes! Your mother, Amy Gutierrez. Come on, dear. I know it's been a while since we talked, but surely you remember me."

Sarah shakes her head slowly. "I don't know if this is a crank call or something, but you're not my mother. I think you have the wrong Sarah. It's a common enough name!"

"Huh? No, baby. Come on, I know it's been about three hundred thousand years, but we're family! Listen, I'm just calling because I wanted you to know that your husband... Jason... he made a mistake. He disbanded my squad and-"

"You have the wrong number, ma'am." Sarah's smile is gone. "I don't know who you are, but you're weird. Keep looking, and I hope you find your real daughter, okay? Okay. Buh-bye."

The video cuts off, and Amy stares, mouth agape, at the screen.

After a minute, she flops around and lies on her back to stare at the blank ceiling.

Oh. Sarah doesn't even remember me. No wonder Jason didn't know who I was when he let me go... she never thought to bring her mother up. I just don't matter to her.

Amy tilts her head slightly to look out the window.

They're gone. All of my kids are grown up, Jorge is in Heaven, my squad is being sent to the lower levels just as I am... this is my reward for hundreds of thousands of years serving the United Earth Forces. This is all I've earned.

Her mind drifts over to the plasma pistol in her jacket, the one she has to return in the morning as her final act of military office. All her medals are being revoked, all of it.

I could pull the trigger. There's nobody left who would miss me. I'd be doing the galaxy a favor.

Suddenly her wall beeps. An incoming video message request.

Amy jerks back up on the bed, her heart suddenly racing. *Did she remember? Sarah?!*

She hardly has to give the order. The screen springs to life, and immediately her feeling of joy vanishes. Onscreen is a familiar face, one she hasn't seen in a few hundred years.

"General Feldmann. So glad you called me."

"Miss Gutierrez... I'll cut right to the chase. I heard you're being evicted."

"Yeah. Housing privileges are being revoked today, actually. I have 6 more hours in this place."

Feldmann holds a carrot in his hand and he shows it off to the camera. "Listen, I know you've always been headstrong about your commitment to the military, but they tossed you on your ass. I warned you this could happen."

"You did. I didn't listen." Amy reaches up and massages her left shoulder lightly. "Sorry."

"What have I always said? One door closes, another opens." A slight pause as he swallows audibly. "Danis is dead."

Amy's blood chills in an instant as if she were being blasted with liquid nitrogen. "Danis? Admiral Danis? How could he have possibly died?!"

"I'm not sure. We're looking into it. Seems my father, the Supreme Commander, brought back a woman from the Labyrinth. A few of my guys have brought me back an interesting report from the entryway scanners. She's 15% Goldeshian."

"What? Goldeshian? But..."

"They're all in the camps? That's what I thought too. If nothing else, I always knew Danis was a fuck-up. I just didn't think he'd bite it this hard thanks to a monster he had a hand in

creating. The woman who killed him, I barely know anything about her, but she has a lot of strength."

"You'd have to be strong to leave the work camps. Stronger than me."

Feldmann chuckles and starts chopping the carrot up. "No, I mean like she's *really* fucking strong. She killed Danis by shoving him against a wall. Standing position. She didn't even put any effort into it. Oh, and get this, my dad said she was his bodyguard."

"He sure knows how to pick them. I don't think I'd want to fight her." Amy leans forward and back, rolling slightly on her butt as she fidgets. "So what's this about? If you have something to say, I'm all ears."

"I've been trying to get you to work for me for a long time now. Private pays better than public, that's my motto."

"Can you get me into good housing? At least middle class?"

"I can't promise anything. I pay based on results. But I'll get you out of your current problem at least. I'll put a temporary pause on your move. That'll give you a few months, but you'll have to do *me* some favors in the meantime, understand?"

Amy bites her lip, but there's no hesitation. "Fine, I'll do it. You're too nice to be manipulating me anyway. I know what you did on Goldesh."

"Yeah? Let's keep that on the down-low. You never know who's listening in on these calls."

He pauses for a moment before continuing. "Oh yeah... my father shit-canned you, right? He's been acting a little weird since he got back, so, sorry about that. Didn't even recognize me at the meeting today... really odd."

"This was before he left."

"Oh. Well, it still sucks. I want you to know that there are still people out there that remember what you gave up. It's not easy doing the right thing, but even if everyone spits on you, never lose that pride. You earned it. Alright?"

"Yeah. Thanks, Steven."

He slides the chopped carrots into a pot beside him. "No, thank you, Amy. I'll be in touch."

"Sure thing."

The video feed clicks off, and Amy sighs heavily.

Well, now I have to bring all my stuff back in here.

Part 404b: The Slammer

Marie lights her 'siguhret' on fire and breathes it in. She told me it makes her feel good, though I think it smells stinky. I don't understand why something so smelly would be enjoyable, but I don't know a lot of other things. It's better I don't ask.

Marie looks at her wrist gadget. "He's almost here. Just another minute or so."

Master is coming! I knew he couldn't just leave me behind! I mean, I was a little worried that he had sent me off with the mean man to punish me, but it turns out he just wanted me to stay with Marie for a while.

Marie is very kind. Master can be vicious, but he has a tender side he won't admit to. Marie, however, is always smiling at me, and she gives me the tasty rectangle bars. I do prefer peat-zuh, but the bars have a nice sweet taste to them. Marie says that's because they have 'shuh-ger' I don't know what shuh-ger is, but maybe Master could get some for me.

Marie doesn't say anything to me for a while, but finally, she mumbles something out loud, all while staring at the building wall-lifter thing. "I wonder if Jason is trustworthy."

I nod along, but I don't think she is asking me a question.

"I'm going to regret this, aren't I?"

She's hardly finished speaking, when Master appears abruptly, his figure visible behind the see-through doors on the wall-lifter. The doors hiss open, and he steps out, that same handsome expressionless look on his face.

I want to say something, but I yawn instead and stretch my arms out. Marie didn't let me get a wink of sleep last night. She just sat there, educating me about a bunch of dull things concerning angels, humans, and aliens. I just wanted to sleep, but she wouldn't let me!

"Did you two even sleep last night?"

Master seems to read my mind, which makes me blush a little bit. It's a tad embarrassing that he can tell I'm tired, but he must realize it's because we were working all night. I think he'll like that.

He pulls me closer to him, and the three of us walk down the hallways to wherever it is he's going, and Marie chats with him about this and that. I don't understand most of it. Several times, men and women will be walking down the hall and pass by us, and each time they will raise their right hands up to their foreheads and pause until Master does the same. I wonder

why they do that? It looks like a sign of respect, but the demons never did that to him. Perhaps Master is a very powerful person, after all?

I mean, he can turn invisible and pop away into different places, plus he made me stronger just by talking, so he has magic just like demons do. That's what I would call powerful, right?

But the people around here in the human world don't look at him like that. He has a different kind of power, like how other demons respect Yama. Master is significant here; he is a figure of authority. I just didn't know that when I met him in the labyrinth.

As Master speaks with Marie, I pull up a little closer to him until our bodies touch. He doesn't notice and seems to be mostly ignoring me, but he does have his arm over my shoulder. Somewhere, deep down, I have this weird feeling, like he has met another woman. It's just a thought, and probably doesn't mean anything. Even if he did, I wouldn't mind. He can have two slaves, or ten, or a hundred. I just don't want him to forget me!

Minutes pass and we arrive at a big sliding door. Master pulls away and looks at me before walking inside. "Stay outside, just stand here at the door. We'll be out soon."

Marie laughs lightly. "These meetings can take up to five hours. Don't force the girl to stand the whole time."

"She can handle it."

He doesn't wave goodbye or anything, and both of them walk inside, leaving me all by myself. I yawn and lean against the wall beside the door. Five hours? Jeez. I'm so tired. I wanna sleep a little bit but I can't let Master down. He's depending on me to stand here, so that's what I'll do!

Another yawn and I blink my eyes a little slower before smacking my face. No! Bad Lora! I have to keep awake.

Why do you stay awake? Why not sleep?

A voice? I hear a voice in my head. Who is it?

I stand up a little straighter and look around. Nobody is around. I'm all alone beside this door... so who?

I can sense your confusion. I have seen you on many occasions, but you and I have never spoken. I am the servant of darkness, Blaarjiim.

You sound like a bad man.

I can't speak, but I talk back to him in my head. *How can I hear you?*

The one named Jason has me in his possession. It's something of a secret, so keep your mouth shut. Ah, wait, that's right... you cannot speak.

I want to... I just can't do it.

I fidget a little, and his voice continues. I have the ability to sense the desires, emotions, and feelings of those born into darkness. Jason holds an intense need to have power over his actions. He does not wish to be controlled by others. But what about you, young girl? I sense much fear in your heart, and only one wish...

You mean, what I want out of life?

Yes. Precisely. You wish for acceptance from Jason, but he rebukes you at every other turn. Such a shame, isn't it? Personally, I think you're too evil for even him.

Evil? You think I'm evil?

Oh yes, quite so. You were born in the darkness, formed by it. You pretend to smile and show compassion, but it is a falsehood. All it would take is a little push, and you could put your 'master' to shame. The events that led to your birth were created over untold eons, and you have yet to fully comprehend their scope.

I don't understand. You say a lot of weird things.

Don't you remember? Of course not. Jason erased your memories of the one he killed. He must see the same thing in you as I, or else he is blind. The way you killed a man with your bare hands, you tapped into a rage that you have always been forced to pretend doesn't exist. After all, no matter how angry you may have been at the death of your mother, you could never fight against a demon. You had to do as they said, no matter how vile the thought. That was your life.

I nod slowly and slump against the wall a little. I suppose... but I didn't mean to kill Danis! I just....

Snapped? Why wouldn't you? It was understandable. I am merely praising you for taking the initiative. My only hope is that your abilities are not wasted as a puppet in service to one with a weaker will. I believe there are truths about your life that you should seek to uncover. Only once you have reached your potential will you be able to make a final decision toward the one you call Master.

A final decision? Like what?

There's a long pause as a sinister face appears in my mind, smiling the whole time. Who knows? I cannot predict the future. Give me something amusing to watch, and we will see how everything unfolds.

I stagger back slightly as I feel his presence leave.

Amusing? He has to be toying with me. I don't trust him. I may have killed Danis, but I had to do it. He killed Melia and Sadie, and he tortured them the whole time. They couldn't fight back, so I had to be their tool for revenge.

But what did Blaarjiim mean when he said there were truths about my life I didn't know? Was he just babbling?

I feel a chill that makes me look around, but there's nobody else here.

I rub my arms and lean back against the wall, wondering to myself where Blaarjiim went. A man that can speak directly into your mind without you seeing him is... a little unsettling.

A minute later, I jump in surprise as the door hisses open. I didn't think the meeting would be over so soon! I quickly turn to face whoever's leaving the room, only for a shudder to go down my body. The man stepping out is someone I didn't ever want to see again.

Danis.

"Eep!" A small squeak slips out my mouth as he starts to walk past me. Is he going to attack? Is he trying to hurt me?!

Get away! I shove him away reflexively and flinch, and a second later a tremendous crash sounds throughout the room. I suddenly realize what I've done and look up to see his body smashed against the wall opposite me. Every bone is broken in different directions, and his arms and legs are facing different directions than they should be, with his head falling forward at an awkward angle.

Just then, Master appears in the doorway, out of breath, his eyes darting to me and then to the body against the wall. My eyes plead with him, but he once again seems to read my mind.

"You may not have meant to do this, but you did. I'll try and clean your mess up. You just behave yourself for a bit."

Marie shows up beside him and curls her lip up in disgust. "Stupid girl. We'll have to take care of this later."

Oh no... oh no... I screwed up big time. This is really bad!

The sound of boots down the hallway makes me turn my head back just in time to see a bunch of people running towards me, all of them in white suits with helmets like I saw Master fight in the Labyrinth before. They aim their guns at me. "Halt! You're under arrest!"

I start to pull back in fear, but a stinging in my side makes me decide not to. Master pokes me in the ribs. "Don't resist. Let them take you away. We'll deal with this ourselves. You need to

reflect on this failure."

His words make me feel horrible all of a sudden. I didn't... I didn't mean for this to happen... oh god... It was an accident!

Slowly I walk to the men in the white armor and bow my head. They jump at me and shove me against a wall, wrenching my arms behind my back painfully. Even my strength would have a hard time going up against their suits.

One on them wraps something around my neck, and suddenly my body feels heavy. I turn to look at Master, but he's already turning away, shaking his head. He's... angry at me.

I'm barely given time to understand what's going on. The men shove me away and I feel even more tired than I did before. The back of my neck stings, as if someone keeps poking it with a knife.

We walk in silence, two on each side, while the persons closest on my right and left grab my arms, guiding me along. Their grip is intense and I want to tell them to let go, but I can't make the words come out. This pain is nothing, however... Master would be even more ashamed of me if he learned later that I cried.

It takes a long time, but the men in armor drag me here and there, pausing at various stations and wall-lifters to take me through different buildings. Soon I don't even know where I am anymore. Everything is unfamiliar, and I start feeling a little scared. How far are they going to take me? What if they send me back to Yama? Will Master come for me?

We stop at a big place with lots of flying ships, just like the station where Master and I first arrived when we got to Earth. This one is different from where we arrived before, and it has a lot of mean looking men, all of them wearing neck-things just like me.

"Put these prisoners in Holding. We'll get to them when the courts are ready in the morning!" A man in a fancy suit yells out to someone else, and then I'm forced to follow along in between all the other people with the neck-things.

It doesn't take long before I understand what's going on. They're loading me onto a flying ship, and all of these prisoners are being sent to 'Holding'. I don't know what Holding is, but it sounds like a scary place.

* * *

Hours pass, and the ship arrives at its destination. I kept falling asleep several times on the way, but the thought of all these people watching me kept waking me up and making me feel nervous. I watch through the ship window as a whole new planet appears outside. We went

somewhere far, far from Master. He won't be able to find me here. I'm... I'm never going to see him again, am I?

It was all my fault. I killed Danis again, a second time. I brought shame on Master. He will probably want to beat me if he sees me again, just like Yama and the other demons did whenever I messed up. Other girls even got killed if they did a bad enough job.

I didn't want to be bad, it just happened. What do I do now? I'm all on my own.

The ship flies for another half hour, but soon we've landed, and I eventually end up just outside a room with big metal bars that go down from the ceiling in rows. The two guards at this place sneer when they look at me. Both of them look like vicious men.

"So you killed Admiral Danis, eh? He put a lot of people in this place, you know. I'm sure you'll have lots of friends here. You'll fit right in, *killer*."

They both smile at me, but their expressions are false, as if they can't wait to see bad things happen to me. "You gonna say anything, stupid? Or are you deaf?"

I shake my head, but they both just laugh. "Look at her! She's scared stiff! Can't even talk." He jerks a hand forward, and I pull back out of fear, but I realize he's only taking the painful neck-thing off. Once he does, he pushes me into the little room with the bars. He slams the gate shut and presses a button on a gadget on his wrist. There's a clicking sound and the door secures itself. "You're a cutie. Just so you know, if they sentence you to hard time, and *they will* since you're a murderer, you'll go to prison. You know what prison is, right?"

I shake my head slowly and pull back from them.

"You don't? It was supposed to be a rhetorical question. Well, you'll find out. Oh, and prison is dual-gender. They say you killed Danis by pulverizing him against a wall. I hope that's enough to protect you."

The men share a knowing nod with each other. "You're gonna rot, bitch! Admiral Danis was a friend of the prison wardens here on Tarus. You ain't getting off easy!"

Both of them turn and walk away at the same time, leaving me to sit by myself, until soon I can't hear them anymore.

I feel my strength returning though. I could get out of here... if I had to. Should I? Master said to behave, so does that mean he's coming to get me? But I'm so far away! How can he possibly find me on a whole new planet?! He told me about the 'galacksee' once. It sounds enormous... way too big for me to see him again.

I don't know... I'll have to do something, but for now, I'm exhausted.

There's a bed in the room. I'll take a nap, and maybe when I wake up, I'll know what to do.

Part 405b: Tarus II

"I can't believe she killed him. I mean, I can, there just wasn't any hesitation. It may have even been unintentional." The words flow freely as I pace back and forth, and Marie watches silently as she leans against a wall. "I'm the Supreme Commander! Can't I get her out of jail?"

My question makes Marie smile. "Jail? We've abolished those. There are only prisons and work camps these days. Since she's a woman, she'll automatically be put into the prison system since we don't allow women to work in the mines. Of course, if she hadn't committed a murder, then house arrest or community service would be possible, but that doesn't apply here."

I pause my pacing to look at Marie in surprise. "Seriously? That doesn't seem a little... gender biased to you?"

"It's not for the reason you think. Down in the mines, too much can happen where the lighting is dim. We had many incidents in the past that were unspeakably awful. I personally believe the women should have just learned to fight back, but it wasn't my decision. The executive administration, lead by Danis, was the one to change those laws. He valued the lives of women, and thus he fought for their rights. He was a good man, you know."

"A good man? Are you positive?"

She nods and stares at me in disbelief. "Yes, and he was killed by your plaything. Danis never once broke the law, he always fought for the rights of demons and the oppressed. When I needed him to quell an insurrection on a planet not long ago, he made sure to use the law to do so. Ironical... he was killed by a person whose rights he helped secure."

I lick my lips slowly. "Yeah... about that. You don't know Danis very well." I start to say something else, but pause as an officer from the crime scene investigation walks up and hands Marie a datapad. "Signature, please. We're done here. Everything was recorded."

Marie looks at me meaningfully, then back to the man. "So there's full evidence of guilt?"

"Obviously we haven't established intent yet, but the entire scene has been processed. It's a level one offense. No provocation. Just sign off here, and we'll send this to the courts."

Marie coughs into her fist and sighs. "That's that, then." With a flurry of movement, she signs the pad, then stamps her thumb onto the finger scanner. The man leaves shortly after and she pulls away from the wall. "There won't be a trial for her. The judge for this district was a good friend of Danis, and the evidence is overwhelming. She's going straight to prison. Fifty thousand years."

My jaw drops slightly. "That's outrageous! Why so long?!"

"It's not long at all, somewhat lenient even. Given *who* Lora killed, as well as the fact that all humans are immortal. Look, you told me that you come from the ancient times, so you probably have primitive notions about the rule of law. An immortal's life is immeasurably more valuable than a mortal's, so if you kill an immortal, you deny them the rest of their permanent existence. The only reason we don't support execution is because rehabilitation is usually possible. After a few thousand years-

"Tens of thousands." I correct her, but she continues as if I hadn't said a thing.

"...she will be released if she managed good behavior during her imprisonment, and the rehabilitation and memory purging were successful."

I open my mouth to reply, but something doesn't sit right with me. "Memory purging? That's... a little..."

"It's perfectly normal. Haven't you ever had memories you wished to forget? The trauma of the past can't hurt you if you don't remember it. Likewise, if our psychologists can isolate the cause of aberrant behavior, such as that which leads a lovely girl to murder a person who fights for justice, then she will be safe to return to the general population."

Eh, I'd be a hypocrite to denounce memory purging. She has a point. There's a short silence as I mull her words over and decide to switch gears. "You've got it all wrong about Danis. You didn't know the man very well."

She scoffs at me and rolls her eyes. "Oh, and *you* did? You've been out of a cryopod for a few weeks and knew the Admiral for all of ten minutes. Don't make me laugh."

I cross my arms slowly and keep my gaze even. "Marie, haven't you noticed Admiral Danis acting... strange? A little out of the ordinary?"

No hesitation. "Not in the slightest. Why?"

I wipe at my forehead before returning my arms to their crossed position. "I killed Danis already. The man in that meeting today was a clone I created to replace him."

Marie's face slowly contorts from an expression of disbelief to one of shock. "You can't be serious."

"I can, and I am. I met Danis in the labyrinth, only a few days after I awoke from the cryopod. I was living with the demons when I met Lora. I've already told you the demons turned her mute... but..."

Marie raises her hand to silence me. "Hold a moment. I don't know why I never pieced this together before, perhaps because I was preoccupied... why was Lora living with the demons?"

"She was a slave, as well as dozens, even hundreds of others. The demons only kept female slaves though, for some reason."

"Oh. I see."

She nods at me to continue, so I do. "Anyway, I met Danis when I was walking with Lora to her old slave room. He was in there, along with two of the other slave women. He had killed both of them, and was... well, he was... violating their corpses."

Marie purses her lips. "An unbelievable story. I suspect that you're lying."

"I have no reason to lie."

"You want your bloody-haired girlfriend released from prison. That is a plenty good enough reason for me."

She doesn't believe me. Shit. If I have to leave Lora in prison, I will, since it was her fault. But the blame is also partly on me for not paying attention. Still, Danis was a scumbag corrupt piece of shit. The demons might be bad, but he had to be worse. I don't want Lora to rot on his account.

Before I can think of a way to convince her, Marie shrugs. "Don't worry about it. Once we sit down and hear Danis' side, the truth will reveal itself. I'll personally grill him to see if your story checks out."

I stare at her blankly for a second. "How- what? Are you going to interrogate his corpse? He's dead."

She nods at me like I'm an idiot. "Yes, he's dead, but he's an angel now. Ah, wait, I forgot. You're new to modern life. The resurrection system guarantees all humans a second shot at life if they should die. This is half of the reason why prayer is mandatory- or did you not know that yet?"

I nod. "Sarah told me in passing. I didn't think about the implications. So you're saying Danis isn't even dead?"

Marie shakes her head. "No, his human existence is over. Once he became an angel, he ceased to be a part of human society. We can go to heaven and speak with angels, and, under special circumstances, they may leave Heaven and come to Earth, as well as other parts of human society, but they may no longer hold office or lead a fulfilling career. Former humans also must abandon any relationships they may have had with other humans, such as with wives and husbands."

I'm stunned. I hadn't realized the resurrection system was a major part of this society. "Even if Danis does have to abandon everything, he's still alive! Why does Lora have to spend fifty

thousand years in a prison if he's not actually dead?!"

"She took away the rest of his human existence. The fact that he is still alive, as an angel, is part of the reason why we don't execute violent criminals. If he and other humans were obliterated entirely on death, then I suspect capital punishment would very much be in effect. Really, you may not be used to the idea of living for tens of millions of years, but fifty thousand is a drop in the bucket. Her sentence is *extremely* lenient, given the circumstances."

Marie lights another cigarette and takes a long breath from it, and I ponder the future while she does. "Marie, when you realize I'm telling the truth about Danis, will you let Lora go free? He harmed her many times in the past. She had reason to be fearful for her life."

"When I do? You mean *if* I do. But in any case, *if* we should find that Danis the monster you say he is, Lora will likely go free, or at least her punishment will be greatly reduced. Moreover, if one of the most influential members of my perfect society is a murderous necrophiliac, as you claim, then I have bigger things to worry about. It calls into question the entire notion my society is based on."

My eyes sweep over her body, looking for cracks in the surface. "You're rather bad at reading people. The fact you had no idea of what he was doing... that says a lot about you."

"Oh come on, Jason. If you're telling the truth about him and not just slandering an innocent man, then he fooled much more people than just me. I'm not omniscient by any means. I merely designed the system that elevates those who are deserving."

"You're saying a corpse-fucker deserved a promotion to Admiral?"

She fumes at me silently before shaking her cigarette in my direction. "I can't wait to prove you're a liar. Once I speak with Danis, and I find the truth, you'll feel the heat."

I shake my head slowly. "I won't. Danis was a horrible man. If he was at the top echelons of humanity, then that tells me something about the rest of them. After all... Yama spoke of others who would use his services."

"Yama, huh?" Marie shoves the cigarette back in her mouth. "He's a demon emperor, Jason. Even if you did see Danis down there, who's to say he wasn't manipulated by the likes of Yama? If I can make a person change their way of thinking without using magic, I'm certain a demon emperor could *with* the stuff."

"You're making excuses for him? Whatever. I'll prove it to you when the time is right." I wave at her flippantly. "I'm gonna go take a walk. I need to clear my head."

"Fine. Do as you please. Just don't try anything stupid, like trying to break your sex-toy out of prison."

"I wouldn't think of it." Marie and I share an amused glare with one another. Despite her harsh words, she's definitely committed to proving Danis is a good man. At least she has a naive faith in him, or it might be for a different reason entirely. I had thought based on my first impression of her that she was a jaded bitch, someone who controlled the galaxy with an iron fist, but she takes pride in helping create a utopian society.

Hell, even if things aren't perfect, there's still the rule of law here, people lead fulfilling lives, government is mostly functional... if the world I came from had kept going on the path it was heading, the failures of the world leaders would have eventually driven humanity to a third world war. I can't know that for sure, but it was very likely.

Compared with that bleak future, a galaxy spanning empire is not that bad.

My only question is... how did Marie manage to get to the top of this system? And if she designed it, why did people in the boardroom not think very highly of her? Is she hiding her true authority from them?

Oh. I see. She must have been telling that limp-wristed Jason before me to do what she wanted him to do. I'll bet she expects the same of me too, eh? Yeah, we'll see about *that*.

I turn to walk away, and Marie speaks up. "Oh, before you go, let me call someone. He'll show you around and answer any questions you might have."

I stifle a chuckle. I see exactly what's going on. She's going to have someone follow me around and keep an eye on me.

She taps a few buttons on her datapad, and a few minutes later I start to turn away again. "I'll be okay, but thanks for the offer."

"He's here." Marie points behind me, and I turn to see the black man from yesterday approaching me. Benjamin Brown is his name, as I recall.

Ugh, guess I'm stuck having her lapdog follow me around. When he's not looking, I'll make a quick getaway.

He stops a few feet away and nods at me. "I'll be showing you around, then."

"Aren't you going to say hello?" Marie winks at him seductively, and for once, his stony expression cracks, and he smiles at her, ever so slightly.

"Miss Becker. I'll see you later tonight."

"That you will."

I shoot a look from her to him and raise a knowing eyebrow. Interesting. I guess they aren't just colleagues, after all.

I push past him, and he turns around and follows after me. I have no idea where I'm going, but the journey might just teach me a few new things about this society I live in.

* * *

The flying ship lands on the dock, and the other prisoners are ushered out before me. The painful stinging thing is wrapped around my neck again, and my wrists are bound by metal cuffs, but otherwise, the guards gave me rectangle bars to eat, and the bed was comfortable in my cell. I'm scared of what awaits me in Prison, since the other people in 'Holding' told me Prison is a dangerous place to be. Only murderers like me go there, and there aren't very many women in there.

I look back and count quickly. Thirty-three men, one woman, plus myself. Master can't possibly find me here. I don't know where I am anymore, not at all.

I look up at the sky and stare in awe. The sky is a green color, and the wind has a stinging feeling to it. It bites into my skin bitterly, but it isn't cold or hot. The bright round light-ball in the sky is less bright than the one on Earth, and redder than it too. That one was slightly orange.

As I look up, someone shoves me forward, but he accidentally pushes himself backward and falls on his butt. I'm too strong to be pushed around like that, even though I'm shorter than the men around me. I turn back to look at him and realize he's wearing a guard uniform.

"What happened?" Another guard walks over to his friend on the ground, who is now standing up.

The guy who fell over leans in and whispers to his friend, but I can hear what he says. "I was trying to shove that daydreaming bitch back in line, but it felt like I was pushing against a steel wall. The hell is she made of?"

This grim situation should make any feeling of happiness evaporate, but somehow his words make me want to smile. I face forward again and quickly get back in line, just in case. These guards have all the power, just like the lesser demons in Yama's domain. Even if he couldn't push me over, deliberately making him mad will just hurt me in the long run.

I have to think about long term survival. Prison is going to be harsh if the Holding guards were right.

We walk across a field with many little green sticks poking out of the ground straight up. The sticks are soft and collapse under my weight as I walk. There must be thousands of them, millions even. Some of the sticks stand up taller than others, and have yellow, red, and other colored balls on top, with soft symmetrical pads surrounding them.

They're beautiful. I've never seen anything like them in my life. The green stretches far off into the distance, where vehicles drive around, here and there. The building we're being led to has a large fence around it, with a big gate that opens up to let us enter. I'd rather sit on the soft green sticks and roll around, but the guards are carrying weapons like those men in white did that Master fought in the Labyrinth. I don't want to die, so I'll be obedient.

The prisoners continue walking for many long minutes, and we enter a large hollowed out cavern inside a mountain. I only know it's called a mountain because Master explained a few things like this to me when we would sleep together at night. I never replied, but he seemed content to do all the talking.

We arrive at a checkpoint and the guards remove the neck-stingers, letting us breathe easier. A tall woman steps forward and faces us, her white uniform contrasting with the other guard's blue uniforms.

"Greetings, criminals and you bad-mannered pieces of shit! I'm Warden Scullis, and welcome to Tarus II, the main prison colony for most of humanity's undesirables! You will be staying here for a very long time, so listen carefully! My rules are law in here! No fighting, complaining, talking back, stealing, or doing anything unpleasant while you stay here! The punishments in this particular prison complex are much harsher than others on Tarus II, because *I'm* the one running the show! Admiral Danis, may god bless his soul, gave me full reign to run this place how I like, and that is just what I'll do!"

She pauses to glare at me. "And in case anyone here doesn't know, this bitch killed our grand leader! Admiral Danis was a man born to lead, with a charisma far beyond his years. This woman executed him in cold blood with no provocation, not even for a perceived slight! I'd watch out if I were you..." She pauses to look at a tablet in her hand. "...Lora. No last name? What, not good enough for you?"

The warden stares at me for a few moments. "You going to say anything?"

I continue staring stonily at her, and she nods at a man beside me. I feel the pressure in the air long before his fist hits my kidney. The impact does nothing to me, but he pulls back his hand and shakes it in surprise, wincing the whole time. "Saint Joseph! I feel like I punched a rock!"

"Oh?" Warden Scullis smiles sweetly at me. "So it's not just an act? I wondered how a little girl like you could take down the Admiral with a palm thrust. You must have trained for millennia to get a body as strong as that. You'll have plenty of free-time in this prison to exercise more, but I'll make sure you have *special* work privileges, so you keep busy. After reviewing the footage of your murderous act, we prepared a unique cell, just for you."

She covers her mouth up and turns away. "Ah, I didn't want to spoil the surprise. You will see!"

Scullis walks away without another word, allowing everyone to breathe a sigh of relief. I expected a longer speech, but I guess she was only interested in me. I already have so many enemies... was Danis loved by these people? Why? He was an awful man. I did the world a favor by killing him... even if it did make Master hate my guts.

We're shuffled off down the hall and my shoulders slump again. Master definitely despises me. I failed in every sense of the word and was locked up. Why would he waste his precious time looking for me? I can't pretend I'll be important to him. Knowing him, he'll forget me in a few weeks.

The main prison appears before us, and I gasp when I see how big it is. It must be fifty stories tall, with a hundred thousand people here. I've never seen so many humans all at once. Many are walking around, their hands clasped together, but most are in their cells, with bars of iron and steel preventing them from getting out. Why do some get to walk around, but others don't?

We're led along, with some prisoners in my group getting pushed into this cell or that one, but eventually, it's just me and the other female prisoner left. She's a little taller than me, with matted brown hair that has natural curls, which are the opposite of my straight hair. Her hair goes down to just below her shoulders, but mine stops at the bottom of my neck.

She sees me looking at her and grimaces. "Keep your eyes to yourself."

I look away, not wanting to offend her. I'm scared of many things, but a fellow woman is not one of them.

I begin to hear a buzzing noise up ahead, and before I can wonder what it is, the guards stop the other woman and me in front of a different looking cell. Unlike the ones we've passed before, which have beds, toilets, and bedding... this cell lacks a bed. It only has the ground and a toilet on the inside.

More importantly, it is not blocked by steel bars like the others, but bars that glow blue. I feel an electrical sensation just from standing a few feet away. A guard behind me chuckles out loud. "Heh, this cell has electrified bars. Scullis didn't want to take a chance on you being able to bend metal, so she set this cell up just for you." He's talking to me, but he jabs the girl beside me. "You'll be locked in here with her too. I hope you're the friendly type."

She doesn't respond, and the guard sneers at her. He waves at another down the hall, and the cell pops open, opening automatically out toward us. Both of us step inside, and the guard reaches for my cuffs. "I'll take these off, but one wrong move and my partner blasts ya. Got it?"

I nod, and he removes the cuffs on both of us. "Smart girls. Welcome to Hell."

He leaves, and the door shuts, but all I can do is smile. *If only that man knew what Hell really was.*

Part 406b:

Ben and I walk for several minutes without saying anything. I keep wondering to myself how I'm going to ditch him without it looking suspicious, but also if I should even try. He's close to Marie, and the two of them are in a relationship of some sort. I can probably get information about Marie from him if I play my cards right. She's shaping up to be the one person capable of opposing me in this galaxy, not counting Zeus. The 'king of gods' is a pretty damn scary figure to go up against, so I'd rather he not end up as my enemy.

We soon arrive on the middle platform between the Megascraper where I live, and the Stratoscraper where I work. I pause to look down through the glass floor once again. The ground isn't visible beneath us, except for patches where the clouds don't cover, and those areas are brown and ugly.

"How do I get to Heaven?"

The question comes to me, and I decide to break the silence finally, if only just because the hushed figure of the man nearly my height is making me feel uneasy. If we just keep walking wordlessly, I'll end up at my suite with Sarah once again... not that I'd complain. I certainly enjoy her company, but now that I'm not in the same room as her, the feeling she exudes in me isn't quite so sharp.

Ben doesn't answer for several seconds, instead opting to stare at a man leaning against a wall in the distance, chatting to someone on his wrist communicator. I could probably hear his conversation if I enhanced my hearing, but it doesn't seem important enough to try.

"You're the Supreme Commander, *technically*, so it's just a matter of going to the Lirius system and using their warp-gate. Why do you ask?" His voice has an edge of suspicion to it. I can easily tell he's not a trusting man.

"I want to speak with Danis."

"Why? If you talk to him, Miss Becker will be forced to assume you altered his mind with Wordsmithing. Your friend will not be freed even if his testimony wasn't affected. In fact, she'll be presumed even more guilty than she already is now, and you'll be under suspicion too."

I lick my lips slowly. Fucking hell, I shouldn't have asked. Now that he knows what I want to do, I can't even try to contact Danis subtly, or Marie might find out. If that bastard lies and Marie believes him, I'll be in deep shit.

"Fine. I won't bother. What do I do, then?"

Ben shoots me an incredulous look. "I don't follow."

"I need to know more about this galaxy. Marie expects me to step in as Supreme Commander, but I haven't the faintest idea what the political situation is. If Marie doesn't want any blunders on her hand, I need to be debriefed on everything I should know."

Ben nods slowly and gives me a meaningful look. "Of course, Miss Becker doesn't trust you yet, and neither do I. Giving you knowledge only makes you more dangerous. Jason 12F never killed anyone, yet you wiped him out with no mercy. The two of you are incomparable."

I shrug nonchalantly and lean against a wall to my side, as several attractive women pass by us, not noticing who I am. It's much more pleasant standing where so many people are congregating, since they're less likely to salute me. The constant attention I have to pay to formality is somewhat stifling; a feeling echoed in faint memories from the other Jason.

"You think so? Funny, you know about my Wordsmithing, along with Marie. How many other people do?"

My question causes Ben to stop and glance away as he calculates the number. "Hmm. Not many. Miss Becker and your senior, the former Jason, were cautious not to let that information slip. Even his children didn't know about his ability to use magic, though his wife, Sarah, did." He raises an eyebrow and grins toothily at me, a look he hasn't done at all in the short time I've known him. "Speaking of which, I bet you're enjoying Sarah's company, eh? She's quite the specimen."

"She is incredibly beautiful, but what do you mean by 'specimen'?"

His smile vanishes. "Nothing, forget it. I'm around Marie so much; I get used to speaking like her sometimes. She's an analytical person, who is almost dehumanizing to those she considers worth looking into. She has always been interested in examining the emotional center of the brain since she believes the Volgrim's approach to erasing emotion might lead to a better society."

"The Volgrim?"

Even as I ask, images of bipedal aliens closely resembling humans, yet possessing eerie non-human-like mouths enter my mind. Now that I think about them, I realize I've heard their species mentioned a few times, but I never thought to inquire more carefully.

"You ask a lot of questions." Ben sighs and stamps his foot on the glass, making my heart tremble slightly. The glass is probably highly reinforced and very durable, but the thought of it breaking and me plunging to my death doesn't excite me.

"I told you already... I need to know more."

He reaches up and fans his hand through his curly black hair thoughtfully. "I could answer all of your questions, but that would bore me to tears. Marie doesn't keep me around for my intelligence, knowledge, or anything like that. She keeps me around because I can read people, and I'm very good at it."

"Is that so?" I smirk and cross my arms at him. "Yet you trusted Danis."

"I most certainly did not. I do not believe the man was as bad as you say he was, but I am always acutely aware of the potential for corruption in a human-run government. The only reason Marie even uses humans is due to the banning of high-level artificial intelligence. She can't possibly run everything herself, so she gives the menial tasks of keeping other humans happy to, well, other humans."

He stomps his foot again thoughtfully and scratches the back of his neck. "Alright, that settles it. Come with me. I know how to answer your questions. I can't say if Marie will approve, but you have access to the previous Supreme Commander's memories anyway, so this can't be much more revealing than that."

He turns and walks back the way we just came, leaving me staring at his back in confusion. I relent and follow after him, simply because I want to know what is so secret he might get in trouble with his boss for showing me.

* * *

A half hour later, we have traveled past ten stratoscrapers and megascrapers alike, and we arrive in another nondescript megascraper that looks exactly like all the other ones.

"Why do all the buildings look the same? Makes it hard to tell one from the other, don't you think?"

Ben chuckles. "Marie doesn't believe in style. Things like art are superfluous. While I disagree, I also understand the feeling. These buildings have to be structured a specific way to support the immense strain on the lower and middle floors. Rather than allow for artistic freedom that might compromise their structure, Marie standardized all their designs. Considering the first Cloudscraper ever built collapsed into a pile of rubble and killed ten million people, with a hundred million suffering long term complications over the years following, I think her reasoning is sound."

I nod as he presses his hand onto a wall. An unseen panel pops out, and he glances around quickly before typing in a long series of digits, far too swiftly for my eyes to even follow. A false wall slides open, and I raise my eyebrows in surprise. "What is this?"

He doesn't answer, instead opting to shove me inside and follow after, only exhaling once the door closes. "Speak of this to nobody. Marie has several facilities where she keeps her secret projects. I am one of only three people who know the locations of all of them."

"Who's the third person?"

"You. More specifically, the previous Supreme Commander. The fact you have his memories means you might remember their locations anyway, so she can't get too pissed off at me. That being said, this is a red-level location, so its existence is hidden. No records of it are stored anywhere."

He taps a panel on the wall and I feel a pit form in my stomach as the familiar feeling of a descending hover-shaft makes me shift slightly. It passes after a few seconds, but I still feel slightly queasy.

"So, what you're saying is... this place is so secret that even the council leaders don't know about it?"

Ben isn't moved at all by the sudden rapid descent to the surface below. " *Epecially* not them. Some of her projects contain fail-safes. Reset buttons. Insurance in case of the worst possibilities."

I stare at him silently for several moments. "Such as... a Wordsmith turned enemy?"

"Use your imagination."

He doesn't directly answer my question, but the faint threat hangs in the air. These facilities are not superfluous. Marie has had a living weapon under her control for tens of millions of years, always worrying in the back of her mind that he might turn against her. I'll bet that in spite of her smugness toward me, she's scrambling to find those old projects again, just in case.

Minutes pass, and the two of us chat emptily about banal things. I glance up at the floor counter and frown. "It says we're on the first floor, but it hasn't moved in over a minute."

"This elevator's display doesn't go lower than ground level since all the underground levels don't exist on any known blueprint. Red level facilities are hidden in a variety of creative places. This one specifically was built underground, forty miles down, and is surrounded by magma. It took 3,000 years to build, and is structured in such a way it could be destroyed at a moment's notice with the proper authorization."

"You mean you'd flood the facility with lava? What about the research? The projects?"

Ben smiles again, this time more faintly than the last time he used that expression. "Marie can always recreate them. Her mind is a steel trap. That is what I love about her." He quickly realizes what he said, and the smile vanishes as quickly as it came. "In any case, the real danger

is letting red-level technology fall into the wrong hands. Not just corrupt humans, but the Volgrim, demons, and even the angels. At least the latter two are too foolish to know how most technology works, but the alien menace have their own secrets. Marie estimates that our weaponry and her genius gives us a 14% edge in a galactic war against them. That becomes a deficit if they acquire our military secrets."

He glances down at his wrist communicator, and I take the opportunity to prod for more questions. "Are the demons even a threat? Why bother with a proxy war if most people don't think about their existence at all?"

He shakes his head at me. "It's all part of her system. The Volgrim are a means to an end, and that end is artificial scarcity."

"I don't get it."

"It's complicated. I don't suppose you know about Energy Credits?"

I shake my head, and he sighs again. "Yeah, I didn't think so. The military consumes about sixty percent of all energy resources that humanity has to offer. The cover story for this is that we need that energy to fight the Demons... but its real purpose is to guard against the Volgrim. To say there is peace between our species is highly fallacious. We've had a cold war brewing for so long I sometimes have to remind myself it exists. Our relations are frosty at best. They see us as emotional primitives, and most humans see them as dispassionate cyborgs."

"What does that have to do with Energy Credits?"

I feel a slight shift as the hover-shaft begins to slow down. Ben notices it too, and he smirks. "Funny you ask. Energy credits are earned by being a loyal citizen. There's only so much energy to go around, even by harnessing the power of stars for our purposes. Replicators require so much energy that they're disgustingly wasteful. Food is reconditioned on the cheap, made from processed garbage. And... what I'm going to show you today would ordinarily cost a *huge* amount of energy credits. Fortunately, Marie keeps a secret fusion generator for each red facility."

He looks at me knowingly. "It's illegal to possess a private source of energy, so you know. Of course, a few select individuals are technically exempt from this mandate. I'm sure you'll understand why."

The hover-shaft slows to a stop and its door hisses open to reveal a long and narrow obsidian-colored hallway leading to a similarly-textured door at the end, nearly 100 feet away. "I can make a guess or two. I still don't see why you would prevent individuals from creating energy for themselves though."

We start walking down the hallway toward the door and his expression darkens. "We experimented once, and gave an extensively planned colony unlimited energy, full replicator and holodeck access. Ten million people. The results were devastating. Over the course of a short five years, they became entitled complainers. Their work halted. They spent more time on holodecks living out fantasies and eating and doing whatever they wanted than they ever did working. If we allowed that to happen with the general populace, humanity as a whole would collapse."

We arrive at the door, and I frown at him. "So you prevent people from having good food and fun... just because they won't work? Isn't that what robots should be doing? What's wrong with having a good time?"

He leans in to allow his eyes to be scanned, then pulls away and presses his hand on a scanner. "Nothing. Recreation is still allowed, but we have to maintain tight controls on the populace. Even Marie knows that to prevent people from having leisure time would be to invite chaos and rioting. Hell, we had that issue on Goldesh, not even four hundred years ago."

"Goldesh?" The name sparks my memory slightly, as the door opens up in front of us. "I heard that name recently."

Ben doesn't answer, and we step into a colossal room, the scale of which reminds me of the area in Yama's lair where I trained Lora and Silvia. Computer screens are scattered all over the place, with large barriers sectioning off several areas where giant machines sit. I spot several slumped over robots in one corner, and a large tank-like vehicle in another. So many objects are visible that I can hardly process them all.

"I wouldn't be shocked. Marie tells me that your girlfriend has Goldeshian blood in her veins."

"She isn't my girlfriend. And how would you know she's Goldeshian anyway? Why would you check her blood?"

He walks forward, and I follow after him. "Marie scanned her, of course. She wasn't about to let an unknown agent stay in her suite. The fact Lora is from Goldesh is quite concerning, given the history of that system."

I wait for him to elaborate, but he doesn't bite. "So what happened?"

"I'm *definitely* not going to explain that. That's why I brought you here."

I stop speaking, and both of us walk in silence for several long minutes, until he rounds a corner into one of the blocked off alcoves. Inside the sectioned-off area, a helmet hangs from

the ceiling, its wires going up into an unknown destination. A chair sits below it, rather stiff and uncomfortable looking, but with a decent amount of padding covering it.

"This is one machine Marie uses on a regular basis. It's the Mk. IIII Memory Molder. This device can download and upload memories at high rates of speed. It's like watching a holographic movie, except in your mind, and you're a part of the events. Unfortunately, due to the amount of energy it consumes while moving petabytes of information every second, it isn't feasible to mass-produce, or holodecks would be rendered obsolete. Marie considered a mass-market version once that merely imprinted onto memories, but the possibility of something going wrong and wiping a person's brain, or a developer error making a memory-movie spam itself ten billion times and over filling their brain... those were not good odds."

A bead of sweat rolls down my scalp. "Uh... so you... want me to take that thing and... put it on my head?"

He nods at me and smiles once again. "Oh, don't you worry! This model is perfectly safe! Marie uses it herself to refresh her memory on past events periodically. If you think Marie would take even a 1% chance of something going wrong with a machine she uses yearly, you're quite mistaken."

I feel slightly apprehensive as I walk over to it and sit down, and I pause to hold the lightweight metal helmet before I put it on. "Uh... if this thing can download and upload memories, what about *altering* memories?"

He nods at me nonchalantly, as if it doesn't matter at all. "I suppose it could. I've never used it for that purpose, but if she wanted, I'm sure Marie could reconfigure it as she wished."

Great. I'll have to make sure I'm never using this thing when Marie's holding the controls. Not that I trust Benjamin either. Anyone as close to Marie as he is must be one hell of a manipulator, and I have lots of experience in that field. I continue staring at the helmet for a while before finally resigning myself to whatever comes next, and I place it on my head. The fit is surprisingly snug, and it doesn't block my vision except for the edges.

Ben watches me and nods once it's on. "Alright. I've experienced this machine a few times myself. The first time I found the experience rather disorienting, but after that, it wasn't all too bad. Just lay back and get comfortable in that chair. The rest will take care of itself."

"What are you going to show me?"

He pauses thoughtfully. "Well, you need to learn about Goldesh if you plan to hold company with that woman, Lora, and you'll want to see some of our formative years as well, and how we created this society. If I show you too much, it could overwhelm your mind, so I'll keep the scope limited."

"Wonderful. Don't melt my brain, please."

I lean back in the chair and stiffen as I feel an electrical sensation against my scalp. Almost immediately, the world around me begins to blur, and that feeling of disorientation Benjamin warned me about spreads all through my body, nauseating me where I sit.

Just before the entire world fades away, I spare a glance at Ben. Did he smirk? It looked almost... almost like he...

My thoughts waver as the world fades away and a familiar person appears in front of my eyes.

It's... me? My face?

Part 407b:

At the back corner of my cell, there's an annoying dripping sound that makes it hard to sleep. The puddle of water that's formed under the metal pipe above makes an audible 'plop' noise whenever a drop of water falls off it.

I roll around a little on my blanket and sigh quietly to myself, then notice my cellmate opposite me has yet to go to sleep. We've been here for five hours, and she hasn't said a word to me. Obviously, I haven't said anything to her yet either.

I gaze at her silently as she spaces out at the floor, and finally, she raises her eyes to meet mine. "What? Why are you staring at me?"

I don't respond, and this quickly annoys her. "You don't talk much, do you?"

My head shake is the only response I can give. Her hard glare relaxes a bit, and she exhales through her nose in response. "Sorry, I don't mean to be a bitch. I shouldn't have been put here, honestly. I didn't even commit a crime. I just caught some of the other girls in my office engaging in illegal food trading. When I reported them, I found out my boss was involved, and it went up even higher than that. By the time I realized my mistake, they'd already framed me for murder."

Her life story condensed into a few sentences. Can't say I wanted to hear it, but if we're going to share a cell, we might as well get to know each other...

Since I don't respond, there's a long awkward silence, and I almost start to think that was the end of her outburst. Instead, she speaks up again. "Are you... mute?"

I nod. "The Warden said you killed Admiral Danis. Is that true?" When I nod again, she sighs heavily. "I always respected the Admiral. One of the reasons I reported my coworkers was because I thought it would be the right thing to do. Danis was a person who was tough on criminals... so if you murdered him, doesn't that make you a terrible person? An enemy of the law?"

My gut tells me to shake my head... but maybe she's right. Danis was a corrupt man, but I didn't have to kill him. Maybe I could have put him in Prison for what he did. Master explained to me what the Law was on our trip to Earth, along with many other things, but I never stopped to think that killing Danis made me a vile murderer, just as he was.

But if Danis was in charge of the prisons, then why would he have himself arrested?

Yeah... that's right. It would have been pointless trying to put him in prison. He has too many friends on the inside.

"No answer to that one, huh? It looks like even you haven't decided yet." She shifts around a little bit and glances at the cell bars. "I can't believe they put us in an electrified cell. But when that guard punched you, you didn't even flinch! I guess they're a little scared. You don't look like much, but you've got quite the bite. They don't want you acting out."

As if the winds of change heard her speak, two guards appear outside the cell and glare viciously at me, ignoring my cellmate entirely. "Prisoner 84721! You've got work duty today! It's just your luck; the other prisoners are *dying* to meet their new friend! And oh boy do we have the perfect job for you!"

I roll and flip out of bed smoothly, landing in an upright position and jumping to my feet, all in a single second. When I eyeball the guards, their smiles are gone. "Quite the agile kitten, aren't you? That's wonderful. Now we know you can handle it."

The lead guard waves his hand, and the blue color of the cell bars fades away. His companion aims a gun at me, and I raise my hands to show no resistance. I don't know how effective that gun is, but Master told me that their weapons could be too much for me to surpass unless I practice against them. We never got that far, due to my arrest.

The lead guard steps in and slinks around behind me, and when he attaches the collar, I can feel his hands trembling slightly. The moment it's fastened though, he breathes a sigh of relief. The collar activates, and I feel a familiar stinging sensation, but it doesn't feel as bad as it did before.

He walks back in front of me, and I resist an urge to roll my eyes. He must think the collar makes me docile and unable to fight back. "Let's get moving! The reconditioners aren't going to clean themselves!"

He leads me out of the cell, and as we walk away, I turn back and spot three other guards entering the cell. "Your friend is new, so she gets her own job to do. I hope she can handle it with the grace you're showing right now."

I feel apprehensive, but there's nothing I can do. I hope the other prisoners don't hurt her, but she has to be able to fend for herself. It's like Master always says, *pain makes you more willing to change yourself and the way you live.*

* * *

Minutes pass, and we arrive at a vast array of machines. Every other prisoner in this area is male, and all of them turn to look at me as we enter. The guards pretend not to notice, but I

almost feel like they're parading me through to show off the new wares. I try to stand up a little straighter, but a buried feeling of obedience returns and I end up lowering my head meekly. This is my life now; I just have to accept it.

The guards walk up to a grate on the wall where a particularly stinky stench wafts out. "The food here in this prison is only 5% reconditioned, and the other 95% comes from our waste! We've had a hell of a clog for the last three weeks, and you get to be the lucky new inmate to reopen the canal! I hope that strength the Warden spoke of is real, or you'll be digging with your hands for a long time!"

A couple of prisoners nearby gaze over and chuckle. "Making a cute little girl clean the pipes, you guys should give her to us for a night."

"You haven't earned that privilege, Zonnis. Get back to work!"

Huh? Privilege? Is that what's going on here? Well, it turns out men are the same everywhere I go. I shouldn't be shocked.

The guard presses a button, and the grate slides over. A different guard hands me a flashlight. "Don't drop this in the muck, or you'll never be able to find your way out. Ha!"

I climb in quickly, my short body only having to duck down somewhat to get in. The men would have a harder time, and would probably have to crawl on their knees.

I stare at the flashlight for several long seconds before noticing a button. When I press it, light beams out. This would have been useful many times in Yama's domain... oh well.

I slowly walk forward, the stench from further down the pipe making my lips twitch. So far it's nothing but metal on all sides in a circular formation, and when I tap the walls, they sound sturdy, as if the pipe was cut directly into the wall.

Not twenty seconds later, I arrive at a ladder that leads down into a hole in the ground. The sound of rolling liquid below me, mixed with an even stronger stench makes my stomach curl up. I shine my light down into the hole and spot ankle-deep brown gunk flowing in one direction at a decent speed.

It looks disgusting, but apparently, there's something clogged in there, and I have to unclog it. This isn't that bad, though. It's nothing compared to what the demons have made me do.

I skip the ladder and hop into the hole feet-first, using a free hand to grab the ledge as I fall in, slowing my descent slightly. I land in the glop below, and it splashes up, getting all over my orange prisoner uniform. It's like I'm wading through a river of thick blood. I shine my flashlight in front of and behind myself, then decide to wade upstream. The thought that by

unclogging this, I'll have it come up even higher to my waist or worse makes me feel ill, but this is just what has to be done.

Not even a minute later, I arrive at the source of the clog. It wasn't far at all. A massive wall of feces has hardened and is blocking a grate, having covered all but the bottom of it. The steel bars that crisscross left-to-right and up-and-down have every hole blocked solid except for the ones at the bottom. Once I unclog this, I'm probably going to be swept away by the current.

I turn back and shine my light at the ladder. It's back down the way I came, but the current is probably going to drag me to it. If I grab it, I can pull myself up, but if I miss...

A shiver runs down my back. If I get swept away, I might drown in feces. What an awful way to go! I'll just have to be extra careful.

My body steels itself as I take a wide stance, spreading my feet out. I lunge forward with a fist and pound the grate with one thrust, and the walls shudder under the force of the blow. Clumps of the hardened matter drop off all over, and immediately gouts of feces blast out from the pressure behind the wall. Still, a lot of it is still left, so I ready myself again and smash directly on the center once more. This time, huge portions break off, and the new stench dwarfs the old one in scope.

Readying myself one more time, I hold firm against the waist-high torrent washing past me, and pound the grate with a final, decisive strike. The grate shatters and the metal blasts outwards, several pieces battering me in the process and knocking me off my feet. I drop the flashlight into the muck and panic, but as the river of brown sucks me down the channel in total darkness, I jerk my hand out just in time to grab the ladder.

Holding on for dear life, my vice-like grip almost crushes the worn-out steel in my hand, and I use all of my strength to fight the current, all while holding my breath, just in case I get sucked into the liquid below. My other hand reaches out, flails in the darkness, and finds the other side of the ladder. One rung at a time, I pull myself up in pitch blackness until finally, my body has escaped the shit creek.

I continue climbing the ladder until the feeling of the narrow crawl-way opens up into a wider space. I flop on the hard, reassuring steel, and sigh with relief. *I made it.* I crawl down the hallway towards the pinprick of light at the end, smiling as it gets bigger and bigger. Finally, I pull myself up into a bowed standing position and walk the rest of the way in silence. When I arrive at the end, the guards hear my footsteps and turn to face me.

"You survived? You weren't even in there for twenty minutes, yet you're already done! Now we can finally return to normal reconditioning speed! You've earned a reward for such hard work."

The lead guardsman smiles at me innocently, but something tells me it's a reward I won't like.

It doesn't take long for me to find out. They guide me to a nasty area stained brown like the pipes in the sewage system. Just as I start wondering what they're going to do, a blast of water pummels me from the side, knocking me off my feet. The water is icy cold, and the frigid temperatures seep through my skin and down to the bone. I can't get back up as the blast bashes me against a wall and won't let up. All I can do is hold my arms up to shield my face.

Laughter can be heard as the guards screech to themselves at the sight of a helpless girl being thrown against a wall, and a painful minute later, the water stops and I sag down to the floor, gasping for breath.

"Haha! That was hilarious! Now you're nice and clean!"

The head guard bursts out laughing again and smacks his knee, as do the other men. Their laughter makes me curl up in fear and anger, and I wipe away tears. These men... all they do is lord their fake power over others. All they have are numbers! They don't even know what it means to be truly powerful, not like Master! He could tear them to pieces without lifting a finger! Master is the strongest man in the universe! Even Yama couldn't stand up to him!

My tears slow down, even as their laughter increases. They love seeing me in pain. But... Master told me something once.

When others attack you in a group, it means they are cowards. They lack the ability to fight you one-on-one. It is these people who are the weakest of all.

I wipe my tears away and pull myself back up to a standing position, then quickly sweep my eyes across the crowd of jeering men. Twelve guards in total, and one of them is holding a long tube of some sort with a hole at the end, and he's aiming it at me! He must be the one who was blasting me with the water.

He stops laughing for a moment and adjusts the tube's angle slightly. "What? Want some more?! Have a drink!"

The water blasts out again, but this time I expect it. It shoves me back against the wall, and the men start laughing again, but now I'm angry. I'm *really* wrathful. I've had enough of pathetic, pissants like these thinking they're better than me! Master wouldn't want me to take this sitting down! He'd expect me to fight with all I've got!

I shove my foot against the wall and use my strength to leap forwards, jumping two-dozen feet instantly as if the water wasn't there anymore. My hand reaches out and grabs the tube-holder by the neck, flicking him lightly with a quick wrist movement and sending him smashing

into a wall. The tube starts spinning out of control and flailing around everywhere, water going in every direction. The metal end of it crashes into another guard's head, knocking him out instantly.

The laughter finally stops, and for once, I spot a familiar look in their eyes. *Fear*. By the time my feet are about to touch the ground, I've already pivoted in midair and coiled up for another jump dash. My foot smashes the ground with the force of an anvil, and I jump at the head guard. His expression is that of panic, and a moment later I slap him with the might of a battering ram, snapping his neck instantly and hurling him to the side like a child's doll.

Master trained me to kill. These men are vile humans. If anyone should die, it's them.

The others fall quickly, and I kill the rest of them with simple ease. This room is off the beaten path, and despite my ferocity, I didn't make a lot of noise. Even so, other guards will probably show up soon.

Just as I am about to punch the head off the last guard, a horrific pain erupts at the base of my skull, and I yelp in pain and fall to the ground. That goddamn collar!

"You crazy demon! Lucky that collar has several settings! Stay down, and I won't set it to lethal!"

The last guard holds his hand over a wrist gadget I hadn't seen earlier. It must be what controls the collar!

I try to stand up, but an even more painful shock erupts through my body, making my arms and legs flop around out of my control. "That was a level 7 shock! How can you still move?!"

I gnash my teeth as more tears squeeze out. *I won't let this man control me! I won't!*

I reach up and grab the collar, then yank with all my might. The steel holds firm for all of two seconds before buckling and caving, and finally ripping off my neck entirely. I jump to my feet and hurl it at his stomach with the rage of a demon who yearns for blood. The man's midsection vanishes as the metal object plows through and embeds itself into the wall behind him.

Wordlessly, his mouth moves a few times, then he falls over, dead.

I breathe long and hard for a full minute before regaining control. I need to get out of here. I don't know if Master is coming for me or not, but even if he is, I need to be proactive.

The walls blur by as I dash out into the main cell block. The far walls stretch out several hundred feet away, and I'm a dozen levels above the ground floor. To get to my cell, I'd have to run all the way around the entire block, but from where I'm standing now, it's a straight jump across the cavern below, and down one level.

I'll jump it, then.

Simple solutions. Master would be proud. I jam my foot into the ground and leap forwards, far faster than I expected. I don't know my power. I don't even hit the level below, but the one above it, plowing through the steel guardrail and into the metal wall behind. I wince in pain, but the pain fades quickly, as have all of my wounds so far. Did Master enhance me with his healing powers too? That would explain many things. He can cut himself with a sword and be healed up moments later.

Getting up, I turn around and hop down to the level below, right in front of two guards who are surprised to see me. Before they can figure out what's going on, I grab both of them and hurl them off the edge and at the ground below with all of my strength. They don't deserve to live anyway.

My cell is only a few blocks up, but already there's a sick feeling in my stomach. The cell bars are locked down, and the blue energy is active, but I can hear the sounds of muffled whimpering and grunting.

Oh, seven hells... I know what's going on.

I arrive at the cell in an instant, and my blood boils. The three guards from earlier are inside. Two of them are holding my cellmate down while the other one keeps punching her in the stomach. "That'll teach the bitch to tell me 'no'! Don't you let her fight back!"

He raises his fist up to hit her bruised and broken body again, but I've seen enough. I quickly grab hold of the electrified bars, and an unbelievable pain shoots through me, but I relent anyway. With all of my might, I yank the bar out, and a huge portion of the steel frame above it comes loose as well. The electricity stops and all three guards jerk their heads up and spot me.

"What the hell?! The other girl!"

One of them reaches down to press a button on his wrist-gadget but pauses. "Her collar is gone!"

That's right! It's gone, and it was never enough to hold me down anyway!

"Let her go!" A voice bellows out and I freeze, realizing all of a sudden that the voice... was actually... my own?

My- my voice? I spoke? I yelled out?

I yelled! I can speak! I have to speak! I can't just let others silence me!

"Let her go!" I rip two more bars out with both hands, brandishing them like swords, as Master taught me. The men gasp and reach for their guns, but they aren't nearly fast enough. I bash the nearest one against the wall behind him with sheer brute force, pulverizing his insides into dust. The next one loses his head cleanly, and the final one I grab by the neck.

"You bad! You bad man! You pay!"

My voice is growly, since I've never used it before, but the sound of it makes him piss himself in terror. I snap his neck and drop him down without giving him a second thought.

Only once they're dead can I finally turn to my cellmate.

She's in awful condition. Her body is bruised all over, with welts covering her from head to toe, and her clothes are torn apart in various places. Finally, there are marks cut into her stomach, probably with a knife of some sort. Not deep cuts, as they're meant to write a message. I can't read the letters though.

She hisses out air and tries to open her eyes, but they're black, blue, and swollen shut. I've seen demons that didn't treat their victims like this.

"Luh... Lora? Is... that... you?"

I nod and realize she can't see me, so instead, I kneel down and sit at her side. "Yes. It me."

"Oh... hah... now you talk..." She raises her arm up shakily to clutch her stomach as tears roll down her face. "Are the... guards... gone?"

"Yes. They leave."

"Oh... good."

She didn't see anything, after all. I look to her side against the wall and spot a small device with little sparks shooting off it. Were they hitting her with the energy from the cell bars? Why would they be so cruel?

I grit my teeth as I stare at her body. I can't heal her, and now that I've killed these guards, I need to escape from here. I could take her with me, and then if I find Master I can ask him to heal her... but how am I going to leave? Even if I can escape this place, Master is on a different planet, and I don't know how to fly a ship!

Oh man... I didn't think this through. I just reacted. Master will be angry if he hears about this.

"Kill... me."

The girl whispers two quiet words, and I feel a shudder in my body.

"No... I can't. That bad."

She takes a deep breath and squeaks in pain. "Don't worry. I don't want... to live like this. My life is over. Ten thousand years... of prison. They will hurt me every day. Kill me, Lora. Spare me."

I can't just kill her! If I kill her, then... then...

Maybe I *should*. If I don't, they'll just keep using her for their disgusting pleasures. I can't escape with her, because I can't carry her and fight at the same time.

My thoughts are interrupted as a sharp, shocking pain erupts in my body. I let out a squeal, and a second later I feel several tiny stinging things stab me in the neck. My body loses control. My eyes stop seeing clearly. I fall forward and slump on the ground.

The Warden's voice speaks up in the distance. "She did all this? Prisoner 84721? This is truly something else. I'm impressed."

I shift slightly to look behind me. Warden Scullis sneers as she returns the look. "You killed some of my best men today. But you still lost, in the end. Enjoy your stay in the Cage."

"No... Lora..."

My cellmate's voice speaks out, but I'm too tired to listen. If she wants to die... she'll have to... kill herself.

I can't keep my eyes open anymore.

Part 408b: Echoes Of The Past

My consciousness swims, as if I'm trapped in the ocean under a sheet of ice, and I can't escape. I open my mouth to speak, but feel a painful sensation in my chest, as if I'm running out of air, but I can tell it's a figment of my imagination.

Suddenly a robotic male voice speaks up. "Calm down, Master Hiro. Take a deep breath. The pain is all in your imagination."

I wheeze finally and fall down a long dark shaft, slamming onto a floor I can't even see. Then, I realize my eyes have been closed the whole time. When I open them, I'm in a pure white room, where the walls, floor, and ceiling have no seams dividing them. It's a white expanse as far as I can see.

"Wh-where am I?"

A floating head appears in front of me, its entire structure made out of rolling ones and zeroes. It reminds me of a movie I watched a few years ago in my time reference. "You are inside the Memory Molder's system interface, Master Hiro. I am Gyro, and it is a pleasure to see you once more. Based on the brain map I have from your previous foray into my system, I can tell that you are a different Jason Hiro than you used to be. Even your deoxyribonucleic acid molecules are substantially altered!"

His voice is elegant, refined, like a British Butler from a movie I saw. I start to ask who he is, but he reads my mind. "Before you ask, my form varies depending on the person I am speaking to. My appearance is designed to be the least threatening being a person can imagine, to help guide them through the memory backup and recovery process."

"Oh. I see. Uh... so, what do I do, then?"

"I do not understand the question, Master Hiro. I presume you came to backup your memory or view previously stored data. Do you not recall?"

I stare at him silently for a few moments before blinking in surprise. "Right, I remember now. I need to learn more about the past of Jason 12F. I thought Ben Brown was going to show me memories of my past."

Gyro shakes his head at me and floats to my side, examining my body slowly. "Mmm. Certainly not. This is a self-guided process. You tell me what you want to see, and I take you there! Everything in here is done according to your will."

I nod and puff my lip out thoughtfully. "Very well, I think I want to start from the beginning. From what I understand, this Jason and I share similar early lives, right up until I entered the cryopod. Can you take me to the day before his- I mean, *my* 18th birthday?"

Gyro blinks three times rapidly. "Request submitted. Receiving authorization. Authorization accepted. Loading memory."

* * *

Instantly, the white room vanishes, and I'm inside a familiar space, one I was at barely even a month ago by my internal clock's count. It's my messy apartment, from before I entered the cryopod, and everything is just the way I remembered it.

"Today's the day." My mouth opens and my voice speaks, but it's not me talking. My body stands up, of its own free will and begins moving around. I somehow detach myself and float away, watching in silent wonder as if my soul was torn out forcefully, yet without pain. Below myself, another version of me walks into the bathroom and starts brushing his teeth.

"What's going on, Gyro? Why is that guy- err, me, walking around? What am I looking at?"

His face appears next to mine and watches the other me brush and gargle. "This is your past, of course. I am not certain what altered your genetic makeup, but it is evident you do not recall anything about the Memory Molding process. You may choose the detailed walkthrough of your memories, where you replay everything as if you were the one in control, or you may watch in observer mode."

"So this is observer mode, right now?"

"Correct."

The memory version of Jason 12F's past continues going about his business, getting dressed and preparing to leave, all while making me feel a sense of déjà vu. I've done all of this myself. Even as he starts to walk out the door, I know where he's going. He's heading to the Cryotek facility to be frozen. It's that same feeling of hopelessness that I once felt; the belief that my life was so worthless, I might as well just donate my body to science. And look at me now, a god among men.

I hover along after him and watch as he speaks to his landlord, the two of them have a rather heated conversation quite different from the one I had with mine, he then marches past the familiar big-box stores, and eventually arrives at the Cryotek facility. The man up front takes his card and asks if he's participant number eight. This is a little different from what I remember, though. When I entered the facility, the man seemed perplexed that I'd need to sign in, as if I had already been there before.

12F sits in a chair in the waiting area and stares ahead blankly at an analog clock on the wall, watching its hands slowly shift towards each position on the dial.

Minutes pass, and I start feeling antsy. "Fast forward to where something happens."

Gyro nods and the scene rapidly speeds up as people pop in and out of the building, and it stops just as a man enters the room. He's wearing a dark black suit and looks like a government official.

"You need to come with me, Jason Hiro."

He speaks to 12F, and ushers him outside into a black van with three other intimidating men. The situation looks dire. I never saw these men when I entered the cryopod, so this must be where our memories split. As the door on the van closes, the world around me vanishes.

"What happened to the environment?"

Gyro smiles slightly. "Naturally we can only render the system as you would have seen it. Once the van closes, you have no ability to see anything outside of it. Such is the nature of Memory Molding."

"But he, I mean... *I* never looked anywhere but forward. How could you know how to render the people walking in the door?"

"I am a highly sophisticated artificial intelligence, Master Hiro. I have the ability to infer a great many things from bits and pieces of memory. Most of the visible area outside your field of view is still something you observed at one point in your life, so I reconstructed it from leftover memory data. Naturally, there is also the matter of your auditory and olfactory senses, which provide me with extra data to determine what is going on around you at any given time."

Most of his explanation goes over my head, so I just nod along. "Oh, okay. Well if I can't see anything outside of the van, let's jump ahead to wherever it's going."

"Most certainly."

I nearly fall over as the world morphs around me, and soon I end up in a room that reminds me of interrogation rooms from those old cop shows I watched as a kid. There's even a security camera and a one-way glass mirror facing inside.

While the other Jason sits in a chair and occasionally gets up to pace around the room, I walk out and to the other side of the mirror. I can't see anything, of course. "I'm guessing you couldn't render whatever's on the other side of this mirror, huh?"

"Correct. It is not something you were able to see at this moment in time." Gyro pauses and stares straight ahead for a second. "Revision, I have access to Marie Becker's mental logs in addition to yours. Given she was on the other side of this glass, I can reproduce what she was

seeing. Would you like to use your admin clearance to access her memories? You are an approved viewer, naturally."

I raise an eyebrow at his words. "I can access Marie Becker's memories?"

"Correct. However, twenty-nine percent of her memories are restricted to Root Admin access. Only Miss Becker may enable access to those."

Hmm. Only Marie can, eh? I'll keep that in mind.

"Well, anyway, let's see her perspective of this scene, then."

"Confirmed. Loading Memory file #07022016874112. File loaded. Processing data. Converting to visible format."

The world shifts quickly and I can easily see the room behind the mirror now. Marie is standing there, looking much younger and more beautiful than she does now. Either she was a goddess at applying makeup, or she's only about twenty-four years old at this point in the memory timeline.

"So this is the guy, huh? He lives in the place where we located the energy signature?"

She turns to another man sitting there and stares at him questioningly. He nods slowly. "Yeah, not a chance it was anyone else. Found him in Cryotek's facility, then brought him straight here."

"That's what I want to hear. I'll handle the interrogation myself. Hand me his dossier, and I'll head in."

"Yes, ma'am." He passes Marie a thick manila folder, and wordlessly she walks into the room where the other Jason is sitting. At this point, my memories are extremely different from his. I don't have a clue what's going to happen, and it fills me with apprehension, as well as a feeling of excitement. I'm watching a story of Earth's history happening through the eyes of someone who shares the same face as me, and little else.

Marie sits down across the table from him and starts talking. She accuses him of something involving energy signatures and other stuff I don't understand, and he merely sits there resolutely until she's done talking.

"What's all this about, lady? Am I finally going to get some answers?"

Marie shakes her head. "I'm asking the questions here, Mr. Hiro. What were you doing in your house this morning?"

"Getting ready to leave. I had an appointment, one you callously dragged me away from."

His voice has an edge to it. He seems angry for irrational reasons I can't put my finger on, but the way he expresses himself feels distinctly similar to myself.

Marie takes his anger in stride. "Your appointment can be put off until later." She glances at her watch. "And if it can't, well, they will just have to deal with it."

She waves a hand at the door and smiles at him. "You'll be taken to your cell now. I'll grab you shortly, and we can run some tests to confirm my hypothesis."

The door opens, and two men walk in, aiming their guns at him. Jason 12F looks annoyed, but stands up without resistance and is led away, while Marie watches him leave. Once he's gone, she sighs. "Honestly, we might have the wrong person. He didn't appear to possess any Heroic Powers. He's just an angsty teenager."

A voice speaks from the other room over the intercom. "Appearances can be deceptive, Agent Becker."

"I'm aware." She stands up and knocks on the glass lightly. "Give him ten minutes to sweat a little bit. I'm going to go have a quick smoke, and we'll take him in for testing afterward."

"Sure, I'll get right on that."

She snuffles and walks through the back door out to where the smoking area is, but this doesn't interest me much.

"Gyro, jump ahead to their next encounter. Get to the good stuff."

The robot stares at me blankly. "The 'good stuff,' Master Hiro? I do not understand the command."

"Just jump forward thirty minutes."

"As you wish."

I feel my brain get sucked around, and I instantly appear in a room staring at that familiar Jason once again, only this time he's sitting in a medical chair with small pads and wires slapped all over his body, while he is wearing nothing but underwear.

Uh, what led up to this scene? I don't really want to know, so I ignore that internal question.

Marie walks over from around a monitor, holding up a stylus and digital pad from a company I don't recognize. It's probably made by the military or something. "Well, the test results are conclusive. You're the one we were looking for."

A flash of anger spreads over his face. "The hell I am! You guys kidnapped me, took me from the normal world into this crazy facility, did all these tests, and now you're acting like I'm some weird mutant freak! Just let me go home already, I already followed your orders!"

Marie scowls at him. "Calm down! This is great news for both of us! You are an extraordinary person, capable of harnessing a secret power unlike any other in the world around us. You have a productive, fulfilling life ahead of you. Honestly, you should be thanking me for giving you this opportunity to shine."

He taps his fingers on the chair's arms silently and fumes for a few seconds, but seems to calm down. "A secret power, huh? Sounds interesting. What can I do with it?"

Marie shrugs. "I have no idea. You have to find that out on your own, though we are here to provide guidance."

He rolls his eyes and quickly starts plucking the electrodes off his arms and body. "Yeah, well, I'm done here. I'll figure out my powers all on my own."

Marie smirks at him as he stands up and wipes his body, a look of disgust spread across his face. "You don't have a choice, young man. Now that we've confirmed you are the asset; you have to stay with us and help in the war effort."

Him and I both share a look of confusion as we stare at Marie. He asks the question we're both thinking. "I beg your pardon, but what war? You mean the War in Iraq? I doubt I'd be much use there."

"The human-demon war."

I immediately realize what she means, but instead, a faint smile spreads across the other Jason's face. "Riiiiight, the human and demon war. I suppose I'll have to fight against witches, goblins, and cave trolls too, right?"

Marie doesn't smile back. "Two out of three isn't bad. No witches, I'm afraid."

The other Jason's expression flattens. "Are you out of your fucking mind? I don't believe this! You can't hold me indefinitely!"

She raises her eyebrows mockingly. "We can, and we will! If you want to escape or leave, I recommend you figure out what your heroic power is so we can determine if you're safe to re-enter normal society."

"Safe? You think I'm a walking atom bomb or something? I'm just an ordinary guy!"

Marie lowers her eyes. "Jason, I'm being serious right now. Trust me when I say that finding you is a joy, and terrifying at the same time. If you think an atom bomb is dangerous, you haven't a clue what the former holders of the Heroic Aura have been capable of. The demonic war is real, and we've been fighting them for thousands of years. You're our best bet for crushing them, once and for all."

Her speech doesn't appear to move him, but as he looks away, unable to meet her gaze, I feel the emotions swirling around inside of him. "Yeah, sure. Whatever you say. Can I go back to my cell now?"

"As you wish."

The two of them walk out of the room, and I hold my hand up to pause the memory playback. "Gyro, is this the point where he- I mean, *I* joined up with Marie?"

"Affirmative, Master Hiro. Of course, the two of you forged an unbreakable bond over the next century, but I don't need to tell you that, now, do I?" His head tilts quizzically, and I look away.

"No. Sorry, I'm just very forgetful." There's a long pause as I consider what to look up next. "Show me the first major event I play a part in."

"No problem, Master Hiro! How does the Founding of the United Earth Forces sound to you?"

My smile comes back easily. "That's perfect. Let's see how history influenced the political climate of today."

* * *

"Wakey wakey, Prisoner 84721!"

A woman's voice sounds off to my side, and I wince, allowing my eyes to flutter open. When they do, I turn to see the Warden staring me up and down, an insane smile spread across her face. "You're the picture of health! Just look at you!"

Huh? What's she talking about? I lower my eyes to look at my body, only to realize that something is horribly wrong. There's a metal mask covering my face and mouth, with just two little holes left for my nose, and two slits for my eyes. I can barely see anything or breathe!

I'm standing up, but also leaning back at a slight angle. My arms are crisscrossed in front of my chest and chained across opposite sides of my body, and my feet are bound together too. I try to move, but I'm held down so tightly that I can scarcely wiggle. What the hell is going on? The last thing I remember was the face of my cellmate and a deep sleep coming over me... how did I end up here? Is this part of the Warden's sick game?!

I quickly take in my surroundings. Tiny room, narrow walls, made of cobblestone, and the door is a massive oaken thing with a slit to see inside. No light source. If that door closes... it's going to be nearly pitch black in here.

Scullis reaches up and grabs my chin, lifting my head up to expose my neck. I barely have the strength to fight back at all.

"You killed fifteen of my guards, I'll have you know. Those were good, family men! They worked hard keeping their prisoners in line! And you, like the murdering scum we knew you were, killed them in cold blood!"

She lowers my head, and I glare daggers at her face. *Those men were sick! They're lucky they had the mercy of a quick death!* I want to shout at her, but this metal mask prevents me from talking at all. I can barely even make gurgling noises with my throat.

"Honestly, I should just kill you, but then you'll end up an angel and out of my jurisdiction. Of course, the heavenly courts can be far more brutal than human ones, but I won't get to *savor* the feeling of your helplessness. I have to pay you back, in full, for the life of each man and woman you killed."

What? Women? I only killed men! There wasn't a woman to be seen!

As if she can read my mind, Warden Scullis pulls a stray hair back behind her ear before showing me a datapad with one of the faces of the guards I killed. "Yes, you killed a fellow woman. All female guards here are instructed to act like men and dress like them to maintain order. You broke her neck, and it took her fifteen minutes to die. A slow, agonizing demise."

She suddenly leans forwards and shoves her face next to mine. "I'll bet you thought you were doing a good deed, eh? The guards here are too mean for your liking; maybe they even made fun of you! What, they bruised your cellmate and had a little fun with her, so that made you angry?!"

A blow to my face knocks my head to the side, but it doesn't hurt thanks to the metal mask I'm wearing. Scullis rubs her fist and sneers. "I don't care what your reasons are, anyone who kills my men is going to stay in the Cage, tied up like a filthy animal for a thousand years! You'll have to piss and shit yourself, and feel the humiliation of others cleaning up after you and mocking you! You won't be able to taste food; it'll just be piped into your stomach until you want to throw it all back up!"

There's a look of madness in her eyes. "You'll be here a thousand years for each guard you killed, and even better, this is just the beginning! Once you're out, I have a new form of torture I've created just for you! You'll wish you were a dead woman in no time! Hahaha! HAHAHA!"

She laughs like a crazy person for several seconds before suddenly calming down. "Ah, sorry, I lacked restraint for a moment there. I'm just so *passionate* about protecting my extended family here. You not only killed Admiral Danis, the greatest enforcer of the law in the galaxy, you also killed low-level guards too! You're unscrupulous and violent, a savage barbarian. It's fitting, of course, given the Goldeshian blood in you."

There's a look of melancholy in her eyes as she stares at me. "You know, many of the prisoners from the Goldesh rebellion ended up here. Some fought back, as their animal instincts instructed, and I crushed them all. The rest learned to obey, and they've turned into loyal dogs in the end. You will be no different from the rest of your kind. I will crush you, or I will break you."

Scullis reaches up and scratches her short-cropped black hair. "Well, there was a certain level of joy among the prisoners from Goldesh when they heard you killed Danis. Perhaps in exchange for the fifteen guards you killed, I should let you pick fifteen of your blood-brothers and sisters to kill. That would be a fitting trade, though nowhere near enough to pay for your crimes. I wonder what Danis would have done with you."

The thought of Danis's face makes me quiver with anger. I'd kill him a third time and a fourth time if I had the chance. I wasn't wrong, he created this prison and hired Warden Scullis. Danis was the cause of so much misery. He was a disturbing villain, especially among humans. A monster who wore human skin.

My fist clenches as I try to pull on the chain holding me to this upright metal bed. No matter how hard I pull, I can't yank it off.

That crazed maniacal smile spreads across Scullis's face again as she notices my wriggling. "Trying to break free? Give it up. Those chains are made of a rare metal called Demon-steel. They could bind two elephants together without issue. After seeing you tear through reinforced steel, electrified to 1,000 volts, it's painfully obvious we need better measures to tame your animal spirit."

Her mocking tone lessens. "Actually, despite the evil you've committed, I must say that I was positively dazzled by your strength and resilience. You might be a vile murdering monster, capable of crushing a demon in hand-to-hand combat, but you're also a fellow woman. I crave your raw power. Perhaps, if you had walked the straight and narrow path, you would be at my side, keeping balance and order in my prison, rather than being one of its inmates."

Like hell I would. I glare at her even more angrily than I was before, though she can't see my face under this metal mask. *I'd sooner lose all my limbs than hold people in captivity. You're no better than the demons!*

She throws her hands up in the air. "Oh well! So much for that! In the meantime, shit and piss yourself as you wish! But be warned, if you make too much noise, I'll come back and give you a *shocking* surprise! Now if you'll excuse me, I need to contact the relatives of the guards you killed."

She waves her hand dismissively at me, as if expecting me to leave, before walking out of the room herself.

The door slams shut behind her, and my worst fears come true. This room is pitch black, like Death itself. Yama would stand out in this much darkness.

A moment later, I feel an awful sensation in my body. My chest starts shaking and tears well up in my eyes as I struggle fruitlessly to try and wipe them away.

I'm all alone... in a pitch black hell. They're going to keep hurting my cellmate, and I can't protect her anymore. What if they kill her, or worse?

If there is a god... please... send help. Anyone. I can't save myself anymore.

Part 409b: Revengeance

"Actually, I would suggest starting a little earlier, Master Hiro." Gyro's blank face hums around in front of me and stares at me with his soulless eyes. "The formation of the United Earth Federation came during turbulent political times and was part of a genius plan executed as a joint operation between yourself and Miss Becker. However, it was the discovery of the Volgrim's existence that put Earth on the path to mass cooperation."

"The Volgrim..." I echo Gyro's words and nod slowly. "Yeah, show me what happened on the day we discovered the Volgrim."

Gyro nods at me. "The Volgrim observed humanity for over a hundred years before we detected their presence. Once Marie learned of their existence, she scrambled to find out more about them. It turned out the Maries of the other streams did not tell her of the Volgrim's existence, nor of many other Red Level secrets."

I raise an eyebrow. "The other Maries? Streams? What do you mean?"

The AI before me stiffens and his eyes turn red for a moment before reverting to green again. "Error, that information is available only for the Root Admin. Would you care to see a different memory?"

"No. I want to see that one."

"You do not have the proper clearance. Would you care to see a different memory?"

I lick my lips slowly and turn away, fuming silently to myself. Then I get an idea. " **Enable.** "

"I cannot enable access. Would you care to see a different memory?"

Huh? My Wordsmithing can't unlock it? Or maybe, because I'm inside a simulation of sorts, my mouth can't open to form the words. That's plausible. Well, if I can't access the memories and learn about these 'other Maries', then I'll have to think of the answer myself. Clones, perhaps? She told me there were no other Jasons, but now that I think about it, Yama told me I was one of many clones. And if I suppose that he wasn't lying, then perhaps Marie would have clones too.

And the more I think about it, the more it makes sense. Marie forged a partnership with a human who could kill her with a single word. Having clones of herself would be excellent insurance to prevent him from killing her off. However... if I'm not allowed to hear about the existence of these other Maries, and Gyro is assuming I am the previous Jason... then... doesn't that mean he didn't know about her clones?

Now that I think about it, that would be a weak defense. Clones the other Jason doesn't know about wouldn't deter him from taking over all the power for himself. And what was the deal with the 'other streams'? Maybe that has something to do with it. I remember from an old TV show that you're never supposed to 'cross the streams' but that probably has nothing to do with there being multiple Maries.

I tap my finger on my hip thoughtfully while Gyro hovers up and down slightly, waiting for my next command. Frankly, if he's not going to tell me about Marie's secret twin sisters then it won't do me much good to speculate. Hell, maybe I can find out using my own methods on her later.

A jolt of agony shoots through my head and I pause to rub my temples. It feels like someone just stabbed me repeatedly in the right eye with a pocketknife. But just as quickly as the pain sets in, it vanishes, and I feel fine again.

Whatever, I guess. "Gyro, take me to the discovery of the Volgrim."

He beeps in the affirmative, and for a second I think I see a glint of hesitation in his binary-shaped face, but it passes just as quickly. "Loading memory now, Master Hiro."

The world shifts around me, and soon I'm staring right at a shocked Marie. Her eyes are wide, and her mouth is agape. "A contact? But how? This shouldn't be possible!"

The room coalesces around us, and I quickly take it all in. It's an observatory, though its location is unknown. A giant telescope is aimed up at the night sky above, and various women and men walk around holding clipboards or other such things. My doppelganger stand a few feet away, a bored expression on his face.

"Aliens? I mean, humanity always suspected they existed. Are they hostile or friendly?"

Marie turns back to face him. "You don't understand, Jason. My contacts would have told me if they existed. There's no way the existence of an alien life form, especially one as advanced as these, would have been glossed over."

"What, are your 'contacts' all-seeing gurus or something? Come on; you're the smartest woman I know. If you don't know about aliens, who else would?"

Marie clams up, and her expression softens. "Friends of mine. Never mind, at least I know now. But first, we need to get in contact with them. President Salvador will want to know about this, and we'll need to gather the World Government together to oversee our first transmission to them. Do they know we've discovered them?"

"We're not sure, Ambassador Becker." A brown-haired young woman sitting at a nearby comm table pipes up hesitantly. "They're located on the... ah.... the far side of Mars. We only

spotted them due to a discrepancy in an image taken by Voyager XIV. The image was ten years old by the time we noticed it."

"Ten years..." Marie swallows audibly. "If they've been studying humanity for at least that long, perhaps they aren't hostile."

"Hard to say. Our leading scientist, Mr. Nielsen, managed to spot the reflective glare of their ship with this radio telescope. He was also the one who noticed the image's out-of-place blurring and spent the better part of five months searching for the object that caused it."

"Well, Mr. Nielson deserves praise, but we'll get to that later. Jason, I need you to go and contact the leaders of the China-Russia union, the presidents of the Eastern and Western halves of North America, and the High Elder of Korea, Kum Jing Onmi. I'll contact the others. You have political pull with the big dogs though, and you can... *get there* the fastest."

The other Jason stands up quickly and cracks his neck. "Yeah, no problem. I'll head out now."

He walks away, and Marie pauses to stare at the floor for several long seconds as an internal conflict rages that I can't perceive. When she raises her head, her attitude is decidedly more optimistic. "If the others didn't tell me about these aliens, they must have had a good reason. This is something I can overcome."

Gyro flies in front of me and nods helpfully. "This day marked a significant change in human history. It helped put Miss Becker and yourself on the path to leading humanity. Of course, her brilliance would have contributed to making that possible eventually, but the acceleration enabled a smoother transition to her vision for an ideal society."

I stroke my beard thoughtfully. "Her vision, huh? So she designed the society of today?"

Gyro stares at me blankly. "Of course, Master Hiro. My, your memory has deteriorated significantly, hasn't it? I wonder what caused this dramatic shift in your mental state."

My eye stings again, and I stagger back and fall to my knees, but it passes again within seconds. "Jesus, what is up with this stinging pain lately? Every so often I get this migraine from hell."

"I am not certain. Would you like to view another memory?"

"Uh, yeah, sure. *Thanks* for the concern about my well-being."

Gyro doesn't answer, and I direct the memory molder to advance to the next relevant scene.

Everything peels away, and I end up in a seat, staring past a group of decorated military generals on my side of the table, while a dozen bureaucrats sit on the other side, one of them

being Chinese, another who looks German, and even a Russian. I have to assume they're important world leaders, though I don't recognize them.

At the head of the table, a massive video screen is active with a bunch of diagrams and a blurry image of a spacecraft, while Marie paces in front of it.

"So this is the best image we've got of that thing?" The Chinese man stares at the screen skeptically. "Ambassador Becker, we're aware of your contributions to the end goal of world peace, and we know you are also a renowned scientist, but that image could be anything! We can't tell the population of Earth about this until it's confirmed! How are we going to manage riots and panics?"

Marie spins around and points at him with a smile on her face. "I'm glad you asked, President Ning. A few years ago, I constructed a prototype spaceship that held the potential ability to travel at the speed of light. However, I was unable to get my hand on a fuel source powerful and stable enough to power the reactor for more than a minute without causing a catastrophic meltdown. If these aliens have been observing us for at least ten years, as I have hypothesized, then as long as we move quickly, we might be able to create a fuel source capable of powering my craft within the next year."

Another man speaks up. "Of course, the Eastern Liberated States of North America are willing to offer our support in any way possible, especially given your contributions over the years, but your technology must be shared among all the world powers equally. No favoritism."

"Favoritism? I wouldn't dream of it. My goal is a unified government, and as much as I wanted it before, Mister Johannesburg, I cannot stress enough to you now how important it is that we put aside our petty differences. These aliens already possess space travel capabilities far exceeding our own."

President Ning raises his hand. "Assuming they are, in fact, aliens."

"They are." Marie doesn't let an inkling of doubt enter her voice. For a moment, I sense her directing hostility toward the Chinese President. It vanishes quickly, and she turns back to the board. "You all have to understand, during the Second World War, the nations who held the aerial advantage were likely going to win in any given battle situation. This is a far more dire event. If these aliens are hostile, we may not be able to survive. They likely have a massive technology lead over our planet, and they have observed us for a very long time. Our airwaves are primitive and easy to intercept."

President Johannesburg sucks air through his teeth. "They know our strengths and weaknesses."

"Yes. You understand." Marie glances at me for a moment, and I see a look pass over her face that makes me think she's saying *ugh, they finally get it*.

A mountain of a man shifts on my side of the table and stares warily over at President Johannesburg. "With all due respect, Ambassador Becker, while your intentions are beyond reproach, and your character is unbesmirched, I think many at this table would not agree with that opinion towards their political enemies here. I came to hear your opinion, and I value it almost more than my own... but after what Johannesburg did two decades ago, I could not see my country siding with his or agreeing to share any technology."

I turn to examine the man who spoke. His name appears in my mind, as do other details rapidly. President Wallace T. Sherman, the leader of the Western side of the USA. I'm not sure of what happened exactly, but something like a civil war split the country in half, and now these presidents rule each half separately. There appears to be a lot of bad blood between them. Just by appearance though, I'd fear the massive bulldozer-looking Sherman over the typical generic politician that Johannesburg embodies. Indeed, he seems very untrustworthy.

Marie looks irritated, but she fights desperately to hide it. "President Sherman, I don't care if Johannesburg dropped ten hyper-graviton bombs on the biggest cities in your half of the country. These aliens might possess technology that can wipe humanity itself off the face of the Earth. Set aside your bickering and focus on the issue at hand." She pauses for a moment to pull a strand of hair out of her eyes. "That being said, thank you for the compliments."

Sherman crosses his arms and leans back in his chair, but he says nothing else. He doesn't look convinced, but I can see he doesn't want to cross Marie either.

Watching this exchange, I have to wonder what Marie did that would allow her to garner such political support. For people to treat her word as gospel and immediately believe her, she must have done many spectacular things already.

I wave my hand, and the scene pauses. "Let's go a little bit ahead, Gyro."

Nothing happens.

"Gyro?"

He suddenly appears by my side, startling me a little. "My apologies, Master Hiro. I was performing a standard integrity check of the backup and restoration subroutines. No notable anomalies were detected. What memories would you like to visit next?"

I scratch my chin. "Can I just fast forward until I see something interesting?"

He stares at me in response. "Yes, I will give you manual control. Of course, anything that is available only to Root Admins will not be viewable, but I'm sure you will understand."

"Yeah... certainly. By the way, just out of curiosity, if Marie is the root admin, can she view all of my memories?"

"Of course, Master Hiro."

"But I can't view over a quarter of hers?"

"Naturally. You are not a Root Admin."

Yeah... that's not suspicious at all. What the hell is Marie hiding from me? Why would the other Jason be such a loser that he would let her have access to his memories, but wouldn't demand reciprocation?

Maybe I should be looking at their personal interactions to find out.

An array of buttons appears before me in midair. One of them is a fast-forward button, as my memories tell me, so I tap it and watch as time accelerates dramatically, by a factor of thirty. Minutes fly by, then hours, and soon the next day arrives. I stop when Marie comes into view. She and the other Jason are having a conversation about something, and since this is the day after the conference with the world leaders, it must be worth listening to.

"-such idiots! I am trying to create the perfect society that rewards everyone equally, and look at what they do! All these men do is whine, bitch, moan, and complain! They're so busy stabbing each other in the back that they can't see the bigger picture!"

Marie's frustration lingers in the air as she stomps back and forth, waving a cigarette around. The wind whistles past on the apartment balcony, and the previous Jason doesn't look amused. He's sitting in a white plastic chair, something cheap looking that doesn't seem like he or she would own it.

"Marie, you're going about this all the wrong way. You can't expect people just to work together, that's not how we operate. If you're going to reshape society, it needs to be a meritocracy. Get these worthless slugs out of the way, and we can focus on putting the right people in charge."

"Well, who are the right people, Jason? Do you know? One human's as useless as another, and they're all stupid and weak! It doesn't matter whether a slug or a turtle is trying to compete in the race for intellect, as they'll both lose to me, the hare."

He rolls his eyes. "You're so full of yourself sometimes. Look, all we have to do is turn public opinion against these guys and get some other people in control. They don't have to be exceptionally smart, though that would be nice. Just get someone in charge of China and another couple of people in charge of the Divided States of America, and make sure they'll

follow your commands without hesitation. Someone is pulling Johannesburg's strings, so he can never be fully committed to your cause."

Marie pauses to inhale deeply on her cigarette. "Have you always been this way? I thought I was the apathetic one."

"I'm just being real, Marie. These aliens are a threat unlike any other. I can't create technology to counter them without being able to perfectly envision how it works in my mind. Our best bet is to take control of this warship of theirs and hope you can reverse engineer it."

"Hope? Not necessary. This is *me* we're talking about." Marie waggles her finger at him. "Also, we don't know it's a warship. It could be a scouting ship. We don't even know what its travel speed capabilities are. These aliens might be all alone and halfway across the galaxy from their comrades, or their home world might be a few light years away, and a full-scale invasion could arrive and wipe us out in a few days."

"Could, might, possibly... that's an awful lot of speculation for the world's greatest scientist, Marie. Shit, this isn't even the full extent of our worries. A lot of world leaders are feeling anxious because of the demon attacks in Francistan. Nobody knows about the angels and gods yet, aside from Johannesburg, and only the wind knows whether he'll keep that information to himself or not. President Sherman doesn't even know what made Johannesburg go to such lengths to split the country."

"Right, right." Marie flicks the cigarette off the balcony and several stories to the streets below. "These things don't matter. In the worst case scenario, humanity has the most powerful hero ever on their side, so the demons will never be a serious threat. Our capabilities for war expand more and more every year, to the point where I'd even assume we could wipe them out in a week, if desired."

He immediately leans forward and punches his palm. "Hell yes, that's what I'm talking about. Just say the word, and I'll tear them to pieces."

A look of alarm spreads over Marie's face, and she quickly flits over to where he's sitting and leans against him. "No no, we don't want that, Jason. The most dangerous weapon is one you never have to use. Just the implied threat of it is enough to scare your enemies away. Once you use it, it loses its ability to pacify others into submission. The demons have had a taste of your power once, and they won't soon forget it. If you allow them to quantify and measure your power, they will find out its weaknesses."

Jason lowers his head. "What weaknesses, Marie? I can make anything into reality with a single word. How could that be countered?" He reaches up to stroke his thin beard. " **Shave.** " It vanishes instantly, and his face becomes smooth as baby skin.

I can't help but feel a little jealous. I hadn't thought of doing that yet.

"Keep the facial hair. I... like it." Marie pulls away and winks at him, though he doesn't reciprocate. Neither do I. Marie isn't bad looking or anything, but she doesn't appeal to me, and I can't put my finger on why.

"Fine. **Grow.** " The hair reappears, and he smirks. "Seriously though, Marie. I don't have many weaknesses."

"You have plenty. Your wordsmithing can be prevented with something as simple as a mouth gag. Your tongue could be cut out. And... there's also..." She pauses to look up at the blue sky, now darkening as clouds approach. "...there's always anti-energy."

"What's that?"

"An invention I made to counter the demons, and the angels too, if need be. However, due to the nature of your powers, it's also a hard counter to you."

Marie spends several minutes explaining new weaponry that can paralyze and even kill anything with large amounts of spiritual energy, and then something clicks in my mind as I pause the memory.

"Gyro, Marie mentioned anti-energy. Do those Golden Commandos have the ability to emit this energy around their suits?"

He doesn't appear. I wait several seconds, then press a button to return to the 'main menu'. Everything melts away and I'm back in the white room again.

"Gyro? Where are you, mister butler?"

Still nothing. I start to feel a little weird. He's been acting a little off for the last few time skips.

A sudden screeching pain in my head makes me stumble to my knees, and I scream in pain. "Graugh!"

When I open my eyes, the pain is gone, but I blink and yelp in surprise. There's a massive black dragon standing on its four hind legs, with both wings outstretched.

"Jason. You need to leave this place. I've been trying to contact you for three hours now."

The dragon speaks normally, as if it knows me. I have never seen anything of its size before. At least a hundred feet from the tip of its nose to the end of its tail, and the wings stretch out another hundred feet on each side of its body. This dragon towers over me, and makes me feel like an ant.

I lick my lips and take a step back. "W-what are you?"

It widens ones of its eyes questioningly. "I am Blaarjiim, the one you bonded with. Let us not waste time on unnecessary introductions. The one named Benjamin Brown is tampering with your mind. He has been trying to insert new memories into your head in order to alter the way you think."

"Blaarjiim? But, you're a big goddamn dragon..."

Now Blaarjiim leans down and brings his head close to look at me carefully. His giant mouth has enough teeth in it to chew me to bits in seconds, and I'm sure a much fatter version of myself would fit inside without much trouble. "What are you babbling about, human? Has the other human one already gotten to you? Are you hallucinating? I have been going out of my way to block his attempts, but I can't stop him forever."

I shake my head at him. "No, I'm definitely looking at a giant black dragon. Maybe you're the one hallucinating here."

He waves a massive claw in the air dismissively. "Again, these are unimportant details. Now that I've finally made contact, I can release you. You need to break free and confront him before he puts an end to your psyche."

My head suddenly rips with pain once again, and I bite my lip to stifle a yelp, and it quickly passes. "So that's what's going on. Fine, get me out of here. By force, if necessary."

"As you wish."

The dragon rears his massive claw back, and my heart stops as it comes swinging at me. The instant it hits me I gasp and breathe out loud.

The terror from that massive dragon taking a swing at me gives me flashbacks of Sarah's demon dog, and when I open my eyes, I realize I'm back in the laboratory, with that weird helmet thing still strapped to my head.

Ben's voice speaks, alarm audible in his voice. "Oh! You're all done, then?"

I reach up and pull the helmet off, setting it on the designated holder beside me before turning to look at him calmly. "Yes. I am done."

His face is pale, and sweat is visible. "Do you... feel any different?"

"No. Should I?"

The nervousness on his face makes me want to bust a gut. Blaarjiim was right. Ben must have been trying to change my brain's physiology or something, and it would have taken a while longer to complete. He didn't expect me to break free from its control.

I stand up from the chair and crick my neck, feeling three hours of motionless sitting take its toll on me. "You tried to alter my brain chemistry, didn't you? Not very smart, for Marie's most loyal assistant."

The sweat on his face drips down as he stands in front of a control panel, stiffly watching me with caution in his eyes. "N-no, you've got it all wrong. I was just... trying to download the previous Jason's memories into your mind. Things would be more efficient that way."

He's lying. Blaarjiim's voice speaks in my mind. *He was attempting to erase your memories and replace them entirely with the weak-willed Jason's. He was trying to transform you into the one you defeated.*

My hands clench into fists reflexively. "Is that so?"

Ben appears to think I'm responding to him. "Yes, I'm not lying! If I were to download the memories into your mind, you could access them more rapidly! It would make the memory molding much fas-"

I don't let him finish speaking. " **Die.** "

The word leaves my mouth and I smile, but nothing happens. Ben stares at me, his face still pale. "Did... did you just try to wordsmith and kill me?"

I don't get a chance to respond. His fingers fly across the display, and a second later, a horrifying feeling surges inside my body as an invisible wave of energy slams me down to the ground. I lose all strength in my body and wheeze painfully, but soon I can't feel anything at all, and merely have to lie on the ground, motionless.

He sighs dramatically. "The former Jason was trustworthy, but you're not like him at all. Miss Becker doesn't see the danger in you, only the potential. She's grown too lax, too willing to forgive. Anything for her greatest pet project. But I won't let you *hurt* the woman I love." He taps his chest. "I activated a personal anti-energy field, just in case you tried anything. As I thought, you immediately went on the offensive. You were unwilling to listen to reason. I'm sure she will understand, in time."

He walks around the panel and over toward me, and all I can do is watch his steel-toed boots draw closer. I put all my strength into moving my mouth, but my words are slurred. "You peash of shit. What are you gonna do with me?"

He kneels down and lifts me up, then shoves me back into the chair before grabbing the helmet again. "I'm going to finish what I started. I won't let you destroy this perfect society that Marie and your predecessor built. I'll turn you into him, and everything will go back to the way it was."

He slaps the helmet on me and walks back to the panel, then smirks as he looks at me. "I hope this hurts a lot."

I glare furiously at him. *When I get this fucking helmet off, you'll be lucky if I just leave you in pain!*

* * *

Everything hurts. My arms have been chained in front of me tightly for so long, and no matter how I struggled at first, I couldn't rip these chains apart. But, I get it, now. The chain binding one of my arms loops around behind the metal slab they have me tied to, and holds the other one. If I pull, I'm just yanking myself around.

How long have I been here? This metal mask on my face makes me feel woozy... I can barely breathe, and I haven't eaten anything since the warden put me in this room. It's pitch black inside, only becoming a little brighter when the door opens every so often. Usually it's a male prisoner, sent in to clean up after me. The tubes going into my stomach gives me food directly, and so I can only do as Scullis commanded, and release all over myself periodically.

Luckily, none of the men have had an interest in me. All of them have been disgusted, but I still feel fearful. What if they take advantage of me as I am? I could crush them instantly under normal circumstances... but bound like this; I couldn't do a thing.

I'm starting to hear voices. People whispering in my ear. They say so many scary things. *Twelve jackals ate the hat, but what makes the world spin?*

I'm going crazy. I need to get out of here! But I can't. How long has it been? A day? A month? I can't tell anymore.

My body screams in pain again as the fire enters me. I have to fight the pain for a few minutes before it washes away, but the feeling leaves me drenched in sweat. I smell like death. I want to die. I don't want to be here anymore.

Scullis ordered a man to stick another tube into my body, this one just above my heart. 'Lava Blood', she called it. At random times, a machine pumps this awful stuff into my heart, and it spreads all throughout my body in seconds, making me feel like I'm being boiled alive. I swear, too, it feels worse every time than the time before.

I just want to die. How could one woman be so cruel to another? She reminds me of Danis, and how he loved to inflict pain on others. It was all to assert his dominance over his victims. At least, that's what Master told me. *Those who attack the weak are afraid to stand up to the strong.*

I thought I was strong... but if I'm chained up and unable to escape, and this weak woman can hurt me in ways I never thought possible, then perhaps I'm just as weak as I ever was. Why hasn't master come? Hasn't it been a year? He must have given up on me. Who could blame him, since I couldn't even escape this place on my own? He was right to be ashamed of me.

A sound at the door makes my body flinch involuntarily. Oh no... no no no... it's Scullis. She's come to hurt me again. Is she going to stab me over and over as she did two years ago? She laughed as she talked about my regenerative abilities. The ability for her to hurt me and the wounds to heal up without a mark meant she could hurt me as much as she pleased and I wouldn't die from it.

I raise my head up, and the blinding light from the doorway stuns me again. A long haired woman steps in, and I feel my knees shaking. Who is she? I can barely see her face through the eye-slits in the mask, but she isn't Warden Scullis. Someone worse? Did Scullis tire of torturing me, so she sent in another person?

"You are... Lora?"

The woman's soft voice is filled with fear as she stares at my nude body. I quickly nod my head, not wanting to displease her. I don't want to be hurt anymore.

She doesn't stand there a moment longer. She steps out of the doorway and yells at someone standing just outside. "Warden Scullis! What the hell is the meaning of this? Is this how we treat prisoners in this day and age? This is barbaric!"

Scullis speaks up, but for once, her voice is shaky and uncertain. "S-she is a murderer, Corporal Gutierrez. She killed fifteen guards. This was the only way to control her. She is unthinkably strong, possibly as strong as your Golden Commandos, but without wearing a Hypersuit. What would you have me do?"

The woman, 'Corporal Gutierrez', seethes and shakes her fist at the woman. "I will speak with this prisoner privately! Give me a light source, and shut this door! You will stand outside and wait!"

I can see a little bit of Warden Scullis's face as she nods vigorously. "Y-yes, of course, ma'am. I'll- I'll have a guard fetch a torch at once."

The younger woman twists away from Scullis violently and strides into the cell, eying me up and down. "And what is going on with this mask?! Get it off at once! I can't speak with a prisoner who can't respond!"

Scullis turns and looks into the doorway, glaring daggers at Gutierrez's back, but her voice is smooth like honey. "Of course, but I cannot guarantee your safety, Corporal-"

"Do it!"

Scullis winces and walks away, leaving the Corporal and me alone. She's wearing a uniform similar to the ones I saw all over Master's tower where he worked, but hers is purple and has a whole bunch of metal decorations and stuff everywhere. I get the feeling just from looking at her that she's an important woman. Her beautiful blonde hair reminds me of Master, as do her soft blue eyes. She looks... pleasant.

"Lora... I'm a friend. Have they been hurting you?"

Her voice is soft now, and she looks at me with pity in her eyes, as if she can feel the pain I've been through. I can't control myself, and a moment later tears well up and roll down the mask as I make choked sobs.

"It's okay... it's okay. I'll get you down from there. Listen, you shouldn't be in here. I represent a very powerful man, and he needs your help. If you agree to come with me, I'll take you away from this place, and you won't be hurt again. However, if you shake your head no, I'll have to leave you here. Do you understand?"

Huh? S-she wants me to help her? Of course! Master must have sent her! He's powerful, and she represents him. Master is a busy man, so of course he couldn't have come here. He sent her to get me out.

I nod tearfully at her, and she smiles sweetly back at me. "Oh, good. You understand. Just give me a minute and I'll-"

Scullis appears in the doorway, a key in her hand as well as a rectangular gadget of some sort. "Here's the key to her iron mask, and the unlocker for those chains."

Amy swipes them away forcefully and shoves Scullis outside. "You stand there until I'm finished."

After slamming the massive door shut, the Corporal presses a button on the rectangle metal thing, and a bright light comes out, lighting up the room, then she turns back to me and reaches around to undo my mask. "I forgot to introduce myself. I'm Amy Gutierrez, leader of the Golden Commandos."

As she undoes the helmet and starts to pull the awful thing off, she whispers softly. "Well, *former*. But Scullis doesn't need to know that, right?"

She tosses the mask to the side and winks at me, but I don't know what she means. Still, I force a smile, if only so she can feel secure. I would do anything for this loving human... the one who saved me.

"Me... Lora..." My voice is hoarse and weak, and my mouth is dry as dirt. I can barely speak at all, but Amy seems surprised.

"Oh! I didn't know you could talk! Everything I've seen about you said you were mute! That will make things much easier."

She undoes the bindings on my legs, then the ones on my wrists, and suddenly the things holding my exhausted body up are gone, leaving me to stumble forward, unable to feel anything at all. She catches me, showing a surprising strength.

"Whoa, easy there, Lora. Just take a minute and let your body stretch naturally."

She glances down at my legs, stained many disgusting colors, and frowns. "Saint Joseph, this is worse than I thought. I can't believe she would... do this to you."

I smile weakly at Amy as I try to pull myself up. "She very bad..."

"Yeah, she is." Amy helps me lean against a wall, then pulls her jacket off. "Here, put this on. I can't parade a naked woman through a prison full of men. It's asking for trouble. Can't do anything about the lower half, unfortunately." The jacket is about my size, just as Amy is the same height as me. If it weren't for my mangled, disgusting red hair, we could be sisters!

My smile widens as a feeling of awe spreads over me. I didn't think people could be this wonderful to each other. She truly is a saint.

After I tear the tubes from my body, Amy knocks on the door, and Scullis pushes it open, forcing her scowl to vanish as she looks at me, and then she replaces it with a false smile, possibly to try not to piss the corporal off.

"Miss Gutierrez, if there is anything I can get for you, just say the word!"

Amy stares at Scullis for a couple of agonizing seconds before smiling cheerfully back. "Actually, there is! I want your pants."

Scullis's smile melts away. "I... I beg your pardon?"

"You're about the same size. You will give Lora your pants."

Scullis stands up straight and crosses her arms. "I have been doing as you say, but I draw the line here. If I were to walk around without pants, order in this prison would-"

"It would be perfectly *fine*, Scullis. Either you give me your pants, or I report you to the Prison Administration and the Council of Three for human rights violations."

The warden blanches. "Y-you wouldn't."

"Try me."

To my surprise, the Warden backs down meekly. "Yes, ma'am. I understand. S-so sorry to question you."

"That's what I thought."

Still, Scullis glares at me as she gracefully drops her pants and hands them over. "Are you going to make her wear these pants while feces run down her legs?"

"Don't worry, Scullis. You won't be getting them back anyway."

I pull away from Amy's shoulder and find I'm able to stand on my own for once. I pull the pants on, blushing as I look at the stains on my legs. To force a human to fester in their own filth like this is abominable, worse than the demons, if you ask me.

With pants and my jacket on, the three of us women and four guards behind us walk slowly down the hall, and I spot the electrified bars up ahead where my cell used to be. A horrific realization spreads through me. For once, a question appears that is more pressing than my fear of the Warden. "Cellmate... she... where is she?"

Scullis doesn't lose stride as we walk past the empty cell. "Oh, that girl? The other troublemaker? She didn't make it, I'm afraid."

The casual way she says this makes my fear melt away, and a savage anger takes hold instead. *Scullis... she allowed that girl to be killed?! This... horrible... awful... vile woman.* I can't believe this! Am I supposed to ignore the death of my friend?!

Scullis turns her head back slightly, and I spot a wicked smile on her face, though at this angle Amy can't possibly see it. "Really, I'm so *sorry* about that girl. But she was a murderer, you know. These things happen in prison."

"What's this about?" Amy looks at me questioningly, but I can barely even think. I've never been so angry in my entire life.

This... this reminds me of when... Master killed...

...Huh? Master killed someone? Someone I loved... who? Who was it? Why am I thinking of this now?

We walk past the gate that leads into the facility and Scullis pauses to let us walk past. "Have a pleasant day, Corporal. I trust this has resolved the matters we spoke about."

Amy glares at the Warden "Yes. I won't report you, don't worry. Enjoy running this facility of barbarism. I pray I never have to enter here again."

"The feeling is mutual."

Amy and I continue walking, and in the distance, I spot a spaceship, small, maybe with room for five people to stay aboard. She sighs loudly. "By the gods, I was lucky. If they had done one simple check, they would have seen I'm no longer the Corporal of the Golden Commandos. This could have turned out very poor-"

I finally stop and fall to the ground, the weakness in my body and the grief from my cellmates death overtaking me. "Gaaaah!"

Amy turns to look at me in alarm. "Lora? What's wrong? Are you alright?" I feel her arm on my back, and her hand is shaking. "I'm sorry they put you through that. It was awful. I fought against just this kind of corruption ever since I first found out, but I can't stop it everywhere."

I shake my head and try futilely to wipe the torrent of tears away. "No! My friend... they kill her! They hurt her bad, then they kill her. Not fair. Them evil. She innocent!"

When I look up into Amy's eyes, she looks away and I can see tears in her eyes as well. "I didn't realize... so that's what Scullis was talking about. The prisoner who died, she was your friend. I'm sorry, truly, I am." She pets my head soothingly and pulls my face to her chest. "Listen, when we get back, we'll go to Heaven, okay? Maybe we can find your friend there. When people die, they are reborn as angels, you see? She must be there."

I nod quickly and feel my tears slow. "Okay. We find her. But... not know her name..."

A feeling of dismay enters my mind. I didn't even know her name. I never asked her what it was, and now I'll never be able to find her again.

"Don't worry! I'll have my *powerful friend* look up the prisoner manifests! No problem!"

Master... of course! Master can find her, he can find anyone! He sent Amy to find me, so if he can do that, he can find my cellmate too!

Just then, the sound of boots come stomping toward us from behind, I turn around to see a hundred men with rifles aimed at Amy and me.

Scullis steps forward, now wearing pants. "Oh dear, *Corporal* Gutierrez, it appears you've deceived me. Your rank was stripped and you were kicked out of the military for disobeying orders. Why don't you come along with me and... answer some questions?"

She smiles at me cutely. "Ah, and you and I can get back to business. Doesn't that sound pleasant?"

I feel my body start to shake with paralyzing fear, but a hand touches mine, and Amy leans in to whisper in my ear. "Don't be afraid; I expected this. If you can buy me three minutes, we can get out of here. Can you hold them off while I run for the ship?"

Hold them off? She wants me to do that?

I turn from Amy's sweet face to the face of my tormentor, and my fist clenches together like solid iron.

Hold them off? I won't let a single one leave alive.

My glare hardens on Scullis, most of all. *You will die last.*

Part 410b: Killing Machine

The feeling of the ship's sonic shower washes over me, and I rub my skin slowly to get the blood off. For over an hour I've pummeled my body with waves of sound to wash the smell of death away, but even after scrubbing my skin raw, I barely feel any cleaner than before.

I finally get tired of trying and switch the shower off, wiping myself down with a towel before stepping into a fresh set of clothes Amy left for me on a ledge nearby. The pristine walls of the bathroom, where the metal has been painted white, blend in with my pale skin. I feel as if I haven't seen natural light in years, but Amy told me I had only been in prison for a few days.

A mirror greets me just before I walk out of the bathroom. The scars all over my face and body are already mending up quickly since my natural regeneration allows me to heal any non-fatal injury.

The people I killed could only wish they were so lucky.

I step out of the bathroom and walk several feet down the cramped hallway until I arrive at the ship's cockpit door. When I press the button to open it, as Amy showed me, she jerks her head up and stiffens as I walk in. A nervous smile spreads across her face as she sets a book down in her lap. "Oh! You're done! I... I hope the shower went... well."

Her nervousness makes me feel weird, so I just quickly sit down in the copilot's chair and stare blankly at the dizzying array of dials and buttons before me. I have no idea how anything on this ship works, and don't think I ever will.

"Yes, thank you for the shower." I mumble under my breath and start picking at the blood on my knuckles. No matter how I scrubbed, I couldn't get it off. Even now, it stubbornly sticks to me, a reminder of the pain I just inflicted on other humans.

Amy's eyes wander to my hands and back up to my face, as she seems unable to look at the blood in the same way I am. "Are you doing okay? You really let loose out there."

A beeping sound emits from the control panel, and she leans forward and taps a button to shut it off, all without taking her eyes off me. She's scared of me now, I can tell. "I'm all right."

It took me a while to figure out who she was. She doesn't appear to recognize me at all, but I knew after spending some time with her... she was the woman in the white armor that Master fought in the Labyrinth. He crushed her, and all of the others under her command, so it's probably not right to think she works for Master.

I was disguised as a demon, and so was Master when he fought her. Even so, after the way I killed those guards on Tarus, I think she would be less frightened of me if I looked like a demon.

"You say you're fine, but I didn't ask you to kill all those people." Amy swallows and looks away for a moment to regain her composure. "You... you tore them to pieces. I've never seen such anger and rage."

"They hurt me, and they killed my friend."

Amy nods. "Yes, they did. It was wrong of them. Even though they outnumbered you a hundred to one, they were still outmatched. I understand why you killed them all." She looks up and stares me in the eyes. "Danis was not a man I admired. He and I both believed in justice, but his ideas of justice were a far cry from mine, and the man whom I represent. Even so, I would never wish death upon him, for I believe my ideals are purer than his. Death belongs only to the demons, who are irrefutably evil."

I scratch at the blood on my fist a little more, but it still won't come off. "What do you think makes someone evil?"

Amy is taken aback by my question. "Oh, well, I suppose that would be... committing heinous acts just for the fun of it? Someone who hurts others for personal gain is also evil."

I nod quickly. "The warden was evil, then."

She cringes slightly and leans back in her chair to look out the viewport, to the stars rushing past us. "You've got me there. I still don't think it's ever okay to kill a fellow human, though." She turns to me and scowls. "By the way, could you please quit picking at your hands? You're going to tear your skin to shreds if you keep it up."

Her abrupt change of topic makes me flinch. "I can't get the blood off. It stays no matter how much I scrub."

There's a long silence as I look away from Amy guiltily, but her next words surprise me. "What blood?"

I turn to look at her, and she stares at me quizzically. I hold my hand up to show her my knuckles. "This blood. It's everywhere. It's hard now, and I can't wash the blood from my hands."

She slowly inhales, and her expression softens. "Lora... there's no blood on your knuckles. Are you seeing things?"

I frown and look again. "I... might be."

She shakes her head and pulls herself to a standing position in the small cabin, ducking down, so she doesn't bump the ceiling. "You need to sleep. Come with me."

* * *

A few hours before.

My body is weakened from being chained up like an animal, but the rage buried in my belly makes the exhaustion fade away. I pull a strength up from inside my body that I didn't know I even possessed, and stand up to face Warden Scullis.

She smiles as her guards aim their weapons at me. "You're going to hold us off, huh? I know you're strong, but a fully outfitted regiment of trained marksmen is a very different situation from catching a few guards unaware. These men and women aren't like the ones you tore apart before. Give up, Lora, and I'll let you live."

My breathing evens out as I stare at her. "You just want chain me up. I... I not let you."

"You won't *let* me? Did I just hear you correctly?" Scullis slaps her stomach and laughs. "Haha, stupid bitch! You don't have a choice! Take her down!"

The sound of the starship behind me activating its thrusters makes my heart warm. Amy is a good woman, an amazing person. Even if I die here, as long as she escapes, I will be happy.

But I *won't* die.

Scullis takes a step back, and all of the masked guards fire their weapons in unison. I'll be dead the moment the blasts of energy hit me.

Instead of standing and letting the attacks hit, I dive to the side and roll, using my momentum to jump high up into the air. The sound of guns firing after me and energy shots whizzing past makes my heart pound like drums. I fall and land behind a big rock I spotted before, allowing it to take the attacks for me. Using all my strength, I slam my bare foot into the ground underneath the boulder, then I flip it up into the air before me, and deliver a punch to smash it at the guards.

Horrible screams sound off as the giant rock blows through a dozen of them, killing the bastards instantly.

Remember to sow discord and fear among your enemies during a battle. This will make them panic and lose control.

Master's words come to me, and I dive once again toward the remaining enemies, keeping a crouched profile as I leap, and using my arms and legs to skitter across the ground like one of Demon Emperor Beelzebub's hellhounds. Even I am surprised by how quickly I close the gap, leaving them no time to group back up.

I jerk my hand down and grab a small rock barely visible under the soft green sticks that coat the ground around me. Using all my strength, I hurl it at the closest guard's head. Their skull,

though protected by a helmet made of something fairly durable, explodes into a thousand pieces as the stone passes through, as if their head weren't guarded at all.

"She's a demon!"

"Get away!"

Cries of alarm go out as I smash my fist through one man's chest, then use his gun as a blunt weapon to beat two others to death. I don't have my sword and armor, but I might not even need them!

Suddenly a burst of energy smashes into my back, and I scream in pain and fall to the ground. Someone landed a shot on me, and it hurts like sin!

"Quick, shoot her while she's down! Shoot to kill!" Scullis barks an order, but her voice is further away than it was before. She must have pulled back from the fight, like a coward.

Only then do I realize something. Scullis's original orders must have been to take me alive. The fact she wants me dead now must mean that she sees me as a threat. And... that's because I am!

I slam my hands on the ground and force my body to jump into the air several feet, giving me a quick grasp on my surroundings. Dozens of them are still alive! Master told me never to let people surround me, so I quickly clap my hands in midair, using the wind shockwave to knock me away from them.

The spaceship sounds louder in the distance. It must be getting close to the time where Amy can pick me up!

I drop down and smash into one poor unlucky soul, then back-flip around, using her as a human shield to protect from the energy blasts coming my way. Once she's dead, thanks to her friends, I use her as a blunt weapon and beat several people nearby unconscious, then fling their corpses at others to knock them down.

Several blaster shots keep hitting me, but the more injured I get, the stronger I become. The blasts hurt horribly, but I keep getting angrier each time. I just really want to tear these people to pieces! I hate them! I hate all of them!!

Things blur in my mind as one person being ripped apart melts together with the next. I lose count of how many I've killed. It's only once I hear a voice yelling from the skies that I blink my eyes and look around. Only a few of the guards are left, but they've given up entirely, and are now trying to run away.

"Lora! LORA! Stop, you've won! Get aboard and let's go!"

I look up into the sky and spot Amy's ship much bigger than I first pictured it, flying several feet above. I nod slowly and shake off the feeling of coldness that is chilling me to the bone. I have to escape. Of course, I almost forgot.

A horrible electric pain shoots through me from out of nowhere, and I collapse to the ground, unable to move. My eyes scan around me frantically, but it takes a few seconds before I spot Scullis, now wearing a suit of white armor, her helmet opened up so I can see her face. There's a whip in her hand, something I saw the demons use several times, but this one has sparks popping off it as she spins it around.

"I underestimated you! You're a monster, a real demon, Lora! But if you think you're just going to kill the men and women that work for me, and that you'll escape, you're dead wrong! Not on my watch!"

The whip lashes out, and I try to steel myself, but the crippling pain it inflicts is worse than anything I've felt yet. I can't move a muscle!

"I was saving this punishment for later I'll have you know! We were going to have such fun times together, but you had to ruin it! Now I'll put an end to you myself, and make sure your murderous ways end here and now!"

I try to move my arms just so I can crawl away, but the whip strikes again, blasting across my back and inflicting a horrible pain. It's just like what the demons and Danis used to do to me... horrible! It hurts so much!

Before Scullis can strike me again, I suddenly feel the wind shift as Amy's ship pulls back a hundred feet. A massive gun lowers from its underbelly and aims at Scullis. She pivots around and aims her back at the ship just as it fires a barrage of bullets. The bullets reflect off her armor and fly in hundreds of directions, but none of them hurt her in the least.

Amy keeps the gun firing for several seconds, but eventually it stops firing, and Scullis turns around to look at the ship warily. "I'd stay out of this if I were you! You should be flying out of here! Interceptors are on their way!"

While she yells at Amy, I clench my fist and bite my lip. The paralysis is already wearing off, but if she's inside that armor, then I haven't a chance at killing her. It's just too tough. Master warned me about facing people wearing it, since even he could barely hurt them.

Master...

Wait. There is a way!

I spot a small rock nearby and grab it quickly before pulling myself to my feet. My body feels sluggish, but my ability to move has almost entirely returned. Scullis spins back around to look

at me but doesn't see the rock in my hand. "Oh, you managed to stand up? You're a sturdy one."

"With sufficient velocity, even a grain of sand can be deadlier than a bomb."

Scullis stares at me, mouth agape. "W-what did you just say?"

"It is just something my Master told me once. Goodbye, Scullis."

Master enhanced my mental speed, my agility, my strength, and even my accuracy. He forced me to train with throwing weapons for days on end, because, as he put it, *if you get in close, you will tear someone apart. But if they can keep you at range, you will need a backup plan.*

He is truly wise.

I flick the stone with pinpoint accuracy. It smashes into the Warden's temple and blows out a chunk of her brains instantly. She remains standing for a second or two before she falls over, flat on her back.

The Warden is dead.

Amy wastes no time letting me relish the kill. "Come on, Lora! We've got less than a minute before we have company!" Her words echo from somewhere inside the ship, but I can't see her at all. I coil my legs and leap up, landing on the outstretched landing platform as she lifts away from the surface.

I finally found my voice... but at what cost?

* * *

Oh man, this is bad. I can't move a muscle, and I feel like my blood is turning into lead. Ben is already over at the console, slapping away at buttons I can't see. Another minute or less, and he'll activate this helmet on my head... once he does that, I'm going to have my memories erased.

My eyes flick around trying to think of anything that will save me. Hazmat suits are hanging on a wall, over fifty feet away. Those won't do me any good. If I could move my body just slightly, then I could fall out of this chair and ditch the helmet. It might slow him down at least.

Think... think! I need to get out of this, but I can't think of a solution fast enough!

Calm down, Jason. I won't let him turn you into his drone.

Blaarjiim speaks into my mind again, and I twitch in surprise. I whisper so only he can hear me. "Can you help me escape?"

His face appears, and now he looks like his usual self, and not like a black dragon. *Listen carefully. My energy is not the same as yours, the demons, the angels, or ordinary humans. I*

have my own energy type. It is not being nullified right now by the anti-energy in the room. Do you understand?

I blink in surprise. There's a humming sound above me as the machine prepares to mold my memories. "No, I don't. What can we do?"

Blaarjiim babbles rapidly at me. *If I merge with your body temporarily, you can kill this human and free yourself. Marie is the one who created anti-energy, and she does not know of my existence.*

It clicks in my mind, and I stiffen as I feel my hair standing on end. "Do it!"

Seconds pass. Nothing happens. Blaarjiim's face is a mess of concentration as he puts forth a ton of effort to merge our bodies. For a single second, I feel something tugging at my heart, but it fades away quickly. Blaarjiim stops, and his face is somehow covered in sweat. *I... I cannot merge with you. We are not linked at all. We must share a deeper connection to join with each other.*

"So what do we do, then-"

I feel a sudden mind-numbing pain as the Memory Molder activates. Instead of sending me into the familiar white room as it did before, this time there's an audible *pop* to my right side, and smoke shoots out, making me wince.

Ben looks up from the console at me. "What? It didn't work?"

"It didn't work?" I repeat his words, and Blaarjiim nods in my mind.

I sent energy into your mind right as I felt it turn on, but our connection is too weak for me to keep doing that.

"Well, do something else then! I can't move!"

Ben notices me whispering and his eyes immediately narrow. "Who are you talking to?"

"I'm talking to myself." I lie, but it's a poor one. He sees right through it.

"Unlikely! Is there someone else in here?" He quickly walks around the console to look at the opposite side of my chair, but when he doesn't spot anyone sitting there, the frustration rages across his face. "Come on! I know you were talking to someone!"

I ignore him and mumble under my breath. "Any time now..."

Blaarjiim's pitch black eyes suddenly shoot open. *I've got it! I will give you a significant portion of my energy all at once. Use your telekinesis to kill this man and flip the kill switch for the anti-energy. It's our best shot!*

"Got it!"

Ben is confused now, so he grabs me by the throat and shoves me back against the chair. "Who are you talking to?! Tell me, goddammit!"

As he does, I feel Blaarjiim's insidious energy enter my body. It's faint, but it makes me feel as if I'm swallowing gasoline, or swimming in a tar pit. It's a sickening feeling, foreign, alien, and altogether unsettling.

Ben's fingers crush my windpipe, but I'm not worried. Something about Blaarjiim's energy makes me think everything is going to be alright.

The pouch at my belt pops open, and a second later, several smooth stones fly out at high speeds, blasting through Ben's gut and chest. Immediately his grip falters, he looks down, and his jaw drops. "Y-you..."

I use my telekinesis to hurl him backward, smashing him onto the floor with brute force. "Get off me!"

I can't move my body at all, but using my telekinesis, I toss the helmet away and hover over to the console. I don't know what buttons to press or what settings to change at first, but a few seconds later, the previous Jason's memories appear in my mind. Wordlessly, I move my arm forward and press the command to disable the anti-energy field.

Just in the nick of time, too. Blaarjiim's energy cuts off, and I fall to the ground painfully. It takes a few more seconds before my body regains some feeling and I can stand up, but when I do, I dust myself off and smile at the man on the floor. He's seconds away from dying. "Heh. You were right, Ben, I did have a friend. Too bad though, you will die alone, here and now."

The life fades from his eyes, but as it does, a smile crosses over his lips. His final expression sends a shiver down my spine.

"He just died... what the hell does he think is so funny?"

A few minutes pass and I manage to relax a little bit and gather my wits about me.

" **Clone.** "

Instantly, a copy of Benjamin appears in front of me. This time, I won't make the same mistakes as I did before. The clone stares ahead blankly, and his soulless gaze creeps me out.

"You have free will. You may do as you please, just as the regular Benjamin would. However, from now on, you will report anything Marie does directly to me."

He blinks his eyes and nods at me. "I can do that."

A thought occurs to me. "Will you answer any question I ask you?"

He nods. "Yes."

"If that's the case, then who are the other Maries? I heard about them when Gyro let something slip that he probably shouldn't have."

"I don't know."

Huh? He's her closest confidante. He has to know. "You're lying."

"I am incapable of telling you any lies. I do not know what other Maries you speak of."

I lick my lips slowly and puzzle away. "Okay, fine. Then what about the other Wordsmiths? Marie mentioned something about me killing a 'fellow Jason'. The way she said it wasn't like she was talking about the one before me, but other Jasons... *in general*. Are there secret clones of me that she has hidden somewhere?"

"I don't know." Ben's voice sounds bored, as if I'm wasting his time and he has a million other things he'd rather be doing.

"Oh, come on! You know something! Tell me, damn it!"

Blaarjiim speaks up. *Jason, your questions are futile. Whatever it is that Marie is hiding from you, she wouldn't even tell her lover. The woman trusts absolutely no-one. More importantly, haven't you forgotten something important?*

"Huh? Like what?"

Benjamin Brown didn't die. He's going to be reincarnated as an angel, most likely.

Oh shit. I... didn't realize that. In the heat of the moment, I killed him without thinking. If he contacts Marie, he can warn her about what happened. That is not good, not one bit.

" **Locate.** "

Nothing happens as my mind wanders the cosmos. Wherever Ben is, I can't find him at all. Though, come to think of it, how did I know to use a word like Locate? I feel as if I've done it before.

"Blaarjiim, I can't find him. What do I do?"

He sighs. *You're going to need to go to Heaven and kill him before he can talk to Marie. I'm not intimately familiar with how Heaven works, but I know that when humans are reincarnated, they appear at a station where they are registered, and the details of their deaths are logged down. The queue is somewhat long, so it might take a while before he can contact her.*

My lips purse of their own volition as I scan the room around me blankly. "Fine. I guess I have to do that, then. But... why couldn't I locate him? Are people in Heaven immune to wordsmithing?"

I decide to answer the question myself, this time by targeting Zeus. " **Locate.** "

A moment later, his face appears in my mind, as well as his exact position. Unfortunately, he's too far away for me to teleport to, though that would expose me as a Wordsmith anyway.

This is all such a pain in the ass! Every person I kill has to be killed twice! What a pain in my goddamn ass!

The clone of Ben turns to me. "Are you fine with me leaving, now?"

"Yes. However, you are not to tell Marie of what transpired today. Oh... there is one thing you could tell me before you go. Why can't I locate the other Benjamin with my Wordsmithing?"

He shrugs. "It could be because now that he's an angel, you've never seen him before and thus cannot locate him. However, the more likely answer is that he is using the anti-energy wrist-communicator he and Marie stashed in Heaven. It is a failsafe in case you were to go rogue and kill either of them. By attaching it to themselves, in much the same way as his anti-energy necklace prevented you from killing him with a single word, this communicator will also allow him to hide from you. Oh, and if he's wearing it, he's probably already contacted Marie."

That last bit stuns me, shaking me to my core. "The other Ben has already contacted her?! You mean I'm too late?!"

"Probably." He scratches his chin. "It doesn't matter, anyway. They got what they wanted from you."

Now I'm confused. "What did they want from me? Wasn't their goal to revert my mind into that of the previous Supreme Commander?"

"No. My predecessor's main goal was to download your memories so he could try and locate the cryopod you came from. Additionally, he was hoping to find out the exact manner in which you killed the previous Supreme Commander. Recovery of the body might allow a clone of him to be created. Reconditioning your mind would have just been a bonus."

The clone stop talking, and my blood stops pumping. I feel dead inside. They're going to find out the previous Supreme Commander is still alive, and being held by Yama. While he probably doesn't have a chance at beating me, I can't be overconfident. I nearly had my mind melted down only a few minutes ago... I'm going to run out of luck eventually.

Marie is beyond dangerous. She needs to be stopped, at any cost.

"Can I go now?" The clone stares at me blankly.

"Well, if the other Benjamin is still alive... you don't serve a point anymore."

He bows his head. "Ah. I thought it might come down to this. I guess you're going to kill me, now."

"I'm weighing my options. Can you help me with information I'll need? If yes, I'll let you live, and you will have to help me out as we go along."

"I don't have much of a choice, now, do I?" Ben's clone stomps his foot and groans. "My life is over."

"Your life? I'm the one in for a world of hurt soon. Come on; we need to get out of here and find Marie."

He nods and falls in line beside me as we head for the hover-shaft. "You're not going to kill her, are you?"

"I am. Don't worry, though. I'll make a subservient clone of her, just for you."

"Nice. You're not such a bad guy after all, Jason."

"I try."

Part 411b: Pain

" **Locate.** " Marie's location doesn't come to me as I had hoped, but that's okay. I assumed it wouldn't.

Ben and I finish riding the hover-shaft out of Marie's red-level facility and step off after a quick surveillance check to make sure nobody was outside. He taps some buttons on the wrist-communicator he pulled from his corpse several minutes ago and then turns to me. "Miss Becker is in your office."

"Oh, you can track her?" I didn't think he could do that, but maybe he's smarter than I expected.

"Sort of. Miss Becker has a secret transponder signal that only she and I can find. It's only to be used in emergencies, but I suspect she doesn't know you cloned me, or that you're using me to get information about her covertly."

His words almost make me feel guilty. *Almost.* "Well, it's our lucky break, then. If you say she's in my office, then she must be there. You can't lie, after all. Right?"

"Indeed. I'd certainly prefer lying to protect Miss Becker, but it seems I don't have much choice in the matter."

Well, that is definitely honesty from him. The two of us walk for a while until we arrive at the hovershaft leading upstairs, toward my office. Once we get on, I turn to him. "You love Marie, don't you?"

He holds his cool. "I do. I sometimes wonder if she feels the same way toward me. Will she mourn the death of my human body?"

"I don't know Marie well, but something tells me she's not the grieving type. However, she is a tactical thinker." I pause for a moment as a thought occurs to me. "Why would she be in my office? If I can't locate her, she must be surrounded by anti-energy. She wouldn't want me to find her..."

Ben chuckles. "Heh, you were right about not knowing Miss Becker. Maybe she did remember my transponder and anticipated you would ask me where she is. You're probably walking right into a trap."

Blaarjiim pops into my vision. *This one is correct. Marie is a cunning woman, and she seeks to entrap you. I would be wary of walking directly into any traps she lays, you're unlikely to escape them in one piece.*

A trap, huh? I ponder the thought for only a few seconds. The obvious trap is my office being pumped full of anti-energy. I've been hit by that stuff twice now. The first was in my office at Marie's hand, and the second time was thanks to the man beside me. I can't keep getting falling for the same ruse.

"Blaarjiim, how were you able to make me move when I was immobile earlier?"

I ask the question, then realize that Ben has no idea who Blaarjiim is. He looks at me questioningly, but I don't bother elaborating. He might be loyal to me and have to follow my every order, but I can't trust him. Honestly, killing him might be a better idea in the long run.

My power is immune to Marie's anti-energy. As the creator of it, she does not know of my existence and thus cannot tailor it to neutralize me. However, if she should find out about me and learn how my energy type works, she will be able to weaken me just as she did you.

Hmm. If that's the case... "Ben, explain to me the differences between all the sentient species and how their energy works."

He doesn't even pause to think about it. "Every race has a different energy type. The angels gain strength when humans pray to them, and they have no limit as to how much energy they can hold, but by using magical energy stored inside them, it reduces their lifespan. Demons cannot be prayed to, but increase their limits when they kill other beings, ingesting their souls to make themselves more powerful."

Ben winks at me. "Oh, and if a demon kills you and takes your soul, you will not be reborn as an angel. Just a heads up."

"Good to know."

He continues. "The Volgrim have unknown properties but other than strong psionic abilities, we've seen no evidence of magical energy. They are like humans, in that humans have almost no magic potential at all."

I lean against the side wall of the hovershaft as we continue rocketing upward. "All this talk of magic, it's hard to believe that it really exists. If I didn't have it myself, I'd think everyone was lying."

"Well, you're a special case. You're a 'hero', which is an individual given vast power by the angels. Only one is born every generation, and another cannot gain the powers of a hero until the previous one dies."

A hero? That sounds decidedly nobler than I imagine myself to be. I'm not a hero, just a regular person given super-powers on par with that of a god.

"Great. Thanks for the information." I turn my attention back to Blaarjiim. "Can you boost me again if we get into an anti-energy situation?"

He shakes his head in my mind's eye. *No. If I had another few days to recover my energy, then I could. Unlike you, who regains your energy every night while you sleep, I am similar to the demons, in that I recover slowly, over time. I exhausted everything for that burst I gave you, and barely have enough to stay awake even now. I'd rather sleep than stay awake.*

He seems whinier than usual. I relent and decide not to press the issue. "Fine, go to sleep then. I have another plan."

Ben pipes up and finally asks the question he's been mulling for several minutes. "Who are you talking to?"

I refuse to tell him. If he becomes compromised, as could happen, knowing about my lone ace in the hole will be awful for me. "Nobody, maybe my other personality. Sometimes he tells me the birds are chirping when they aren't."

"Birds?"

His question makes me frown. "You don't know what a friggin' bird is?"

"Sounds familiar but I don't know for sure."

"Never mind."

* * *

Once the hover-shaft reaches the top, we both step out and quickly make our way down hallways and past rooms, beelining straight for my office. Sometimes a uniformed officer will salute me, but I ignore them. I'm in too much of a rush.

A familiar corridor opens up before me, and I breathe slowly. My office is just around the corner. We walk forward a few feet and I spot my assistant, dozing off at the desk. I want to just ignore her, but as if she has a sixth sense and a knack for detecting me, she jerks her head up and stares at me in confusion. "O-oh! Commander Hiro! I didn't expect you at the office today!" She stands up and bangs her knee on the desk, wincing afterward. "Owie, shoot. Uh, I have these memos you need to sign, they're from General-"

I interrupt her. "Is there anyone in my office?"

Stephanie is confused by my question. "Huh? Not that I know of. Why?"

"Just curious. Were you sleeping at your desk?"

She stiffens. "Well, I mean, it's been a long day, and I had all this paperwork, and I-"

"Of course. I'm going in, now." I have to hold back anger at her incompetence in order to prevent myself from rolling my eyes, but as Ben and I continue walking past, I catch a glimpse of that stupid speechless expression on her face, and in an instant, I decide I've had enough.

"You know what, Stephanie? Go home. You're fired. Pack up your belongings and leave."

Even Ben looks surprised. "You're firing her?"

"Yes. I need people I can *trust*, individuals who can do their jobs. Clearly, Stephanie doesn't understand the meaning of discipline."

When I turn back to look at her, no tears are visible in her eyes. She looks a little gloomy, but otherwise, she's taking it rather well. "Ah... you don't trust me. I understand. That's how it is. How long have you thought like this?"

This time I really do roll my eyes. "Since I first met you. I don't think you've ever gone a day without screwing things up."

She swallows and reaches down to pick up a bag with her belongings in it. "I understand. I'm sorry I disappointed you, Supreme Commander."

Without another word, she walks past us quickly, keeping her head bowed. Funny, for a moment there, I felt almost like the clumsy girl thing was all an act, a ruse. She suddenly seemed sharper and more confident. Maybe the job was just too much pressure for her. Working for a guy like the previous Jason, a stickler for the rules... it would have been harrowing, to say the least. A moment later the thought passes and I've already moved on.

I turn to my office door, and its AI speaks up. "Hello, Commander Jason Hiro. How are you feeling today?"

"I'm fine, Samuel. Is Marie Becker in my office?"

The AI beeps a negative tone. "No, she is not. I will unlock the doors for you."

Huh? She isn't? Did Ben trick me?

The door opens, and I sigh as I spot her, sitting in my chair. She's leaning back lazily, without a care in the world, and for once she isn't smoking.

"Jason. Ben. Glad you two showed up."

"You were expecting us, then." My question is rhetorical, and she quickly picks up on that.

"Of course. The transponder that you used to track me here also tracked your position."

I shoot a look at Ben, and he shrugs in response. "Hey, I'm not the genius here... she is. She made the system."

"Well, Marie, what do we do now, huh? You invaded my mind, stole my memories, and tried to change me into a different person. You must really have wanted me pissed off."

She slowly leans forward in the chair. "Not so. I never asked Benjamin to do anything like that. In fact, he betrayed my confidence, something he's never done in the millions of years I've known him."

"Hey, I'm standing here too." Ben waves at her. "For your information, I didn't trust Jason one bit. You're too naive, Miss Becker. You don't know people like I do. Isn't that why you brought me on? In the end, he killed me and made a clone of me, so I was right."

Marie's expression goes rigid. "You brought that fate on yourself, Benjamin. You instigated him and failed in the end. You've already received your punishment. I killed your angelic counterpart when I found out about your colossal mistake, and I'd kill you right now if I thought Jason wouldn't mind."

Ben quiets down. "You... killed me? But, we're partners. I thought you... to me--"

She curls her lip in disgust. "I valued you for your loyalty and skills. If you warmed the bed up a few times, that was just a bonus. I don't want to talk with you for even another second, so keep your mouth shut."

Ben follows her orders timidly and bows his head. I feel sadness spilling from his body in waves, since he can't believe she'd kill him so easily.

But for me, it's obvious. Marie and I are similar to one another, in that we view other people as tools. I don't trust her, and she doesn't trust me.

"Marie, let's get back on topic. You've had hours to look at my memories, so I'm giving you one chance to explain yourself. If you're going to know everything about me, I deserve to know everything about you. It's that simple."

She raises her eyebrows. "I don't think so. The secrets that I hold are integral to protecting the universe itself. You can never know them."

"Sure I can. Just tell me about the other Maries."

Her half-smile fades instantly. "Where did you hear about them?"

"The Memory Molder. You had a few memories unlocked."

She relaxes a little. "Ah, so you don't know anything after all. It's impossible for you to have recovered information about my hidden memories. I spent several millennia perfecting the machine before ever allowing Jason 12F to use it."

I take a step toward my desk. "You do have something you're hiding! Tell me! This is the only way to repair our relations!"

She shakes her head. "Not a chance. Jason, some things are bigger than the both of us."

"Well, you're so righteous and full of goodness. Why don't you explain those things to me?"

She looks irritated. "I see it in your eyes. You want to force me to tell you, but you can't manipulate free will. Wordsmithing has at least that one limitation."

"I could kill you and make a clone. The clone would tell me everything."

Ben nods to my side. "Accurate."

Marie ignores him. "You know, Jason, I've done a lot of dirty deeds in my life. When your predecessor and I rose to power, we did everything in our power to take control, but he was never essential to my plans. He was merely a convenience."

"Where are you going with this?"

She purses her lips. "You're a danger to everything. Jason 12F and I spent so much time creating this society, and you threaten to throw everything into chaos. I can't have that."

With a flurry of movement, her finger moves to the side. A tingling fills my body, but otherwise, nothing happens. Marie smiles at me and breathes a sigh of relief. "I had to neutralize you. With you out of the equation, I can--"

Marie pauses to stare at me in shock. "You're not collapsing? I activated the anti-energy... I know I did!"

I nod sagely. "Yes, you did. However, before I came in this room, I expelled all the energy from my body. Anti-energy has no effect on beings without magical powers, like ordinary humans."

I reach behind myself and pull out a blaster pistol, then aim it at her chest. "I'd like to say that this is my win, but we both know that's not really you sitting in that chair."

Ben turns to me in confusion. "What? That's not Miss Becker?"

"No. That's an android, designed to look exactly like her. That's why Samuel said she wasn't inside."

Marie waves her finger at me chidingly. "You were correct, until that last part. I'm not an android, but a hologram. I'm nowhere near you right now."

Oh. Well, at least I was on the right track. I fire a shot of energy at her, and it passes through her chest, blowing the back side of the chair off cleanly. "Clever girl. You were a coward, as I expected. What, afraid this demigod would tear you to pieces?"

"No. I was worried you would clone me and gain access to my memories, as you did to Benjamin. I now know where the other Jason is, as well as your cryopod, and many other details of your life since arriving here. I have a slight edge over you, but it's all for naught, in the end."

There's a long pause as she looks past us to stare at the wall, all while playing with her hair. "I'm going to leave for a while. Don't bother trying to find me... you will fail. I'm going to find some friends who can take restrain your savagery, and when I come back, you won't have a prayer of winning."

"You will try."

She ignores my comeback. "I can only hope that while I am gone, you don't have the time to destroy this society. Perhaps by the time I return, you will have understood my intentions, and we can work together without bloodshed. However, if I return and this human civilization is even marginally worse off than when I left, you will feel my wrath."

"What, you don't have faith in me? I'll tell you what, Marie. Bring whoever you want. While you're gone, I'll improve life for everyone. When you bring back these killers, I'll take all of them down, effortlessly. You do your worst, and I'll do my best."

Marie nods. "So be it." She pivots to face Ben. "I know you don't really have a say in fighting Jason, and you can't help being a traitor anymore, but I still irrationally hate you for turning coat. When I return, you will suffer as well."

Ben curls his lip up in revulsion. "I can't believe I ever liked you."

Marie doesn't reply. A moment later, she taps an unseen button, and her hologram vanishes. The two of us stare at her missing visage and sigh. What happens now?

* * *

Ah, well, at least *that* unpleasant business is over.

I turn my head to look at the ship display before me. The secret outpost I built just inside Jupiter's rings over thirty million years ago is still undiscovered. The cloaking technology has needed a buff here and there, but otherwise, the station is in excellent condition.

The computer speaks to me. "Marie Becker, I have sent the instructions to your co-engineer, as requested. He was annoyed with the fact you were taking a vacation so suddenly, but I believe he will do an excellent job in your absence."

"Of course. I wouldn't name some idiot as my number two." I groan to myself as the ship's sensors point at something unseen, hidden in the planet's rings. Human eyes and most sensor systems can't detect the station at all, but of course it becomes a lot easier to find if you know what you're looking for.

This station is my only way of sending and receiving visitors from other universes. I did not build it, and I am not allowed to understand how it works. Alpha Marie, the very first of my sisters, was the one to create it. She is older than all of us combined, and is the one who created the communication system we all use. I could only pray I someday understand how it all works, but even if I did, she would wipe my memory. Sources are not allowed to know the minutia of the multiverse.

A few minutes pass, and I dock inside the station, allowing its stealth mode to reactivate once more. All at once, advanced robots step out of the walls to greet me and lead me to the main communications room. Honestly, I've forgotten the layout of the place since it's been so long. Aside from yesterday when I contacted the other Maries to tell them about this new Jason, it must have been a few million years since I last made contact. We aren't best friends or anything like that.

I arrive in the conference room and take a seat at the table. It only takes a minute or so before holograms of a dozen other Maries pop up in the chairs around the table. "Marie 12F, why are you here?"

I can't help but feel slightly nervous. Some of these Maries on the council are older than me and have lived through much more turbulent wars than I could even imagine. After all, I put an end to war itself in my universe.

"You might recall that I contacted you about a new Source Jason? The third one."

The Marie who just spoke blinks heavily. "Yes. What about him?"

"He is taking control of the human empire I established. I require assistance to stop him."

She balks at my request. "You're a Marie! Jasons and Maries cannot logically compete on a brain power level! Just destroy him and be done with it!"

"That's a simple thing to say, but this Jason is different. He's more cunning than I had thought. He didn't kill Jason 12F, as I initially reported, but instead incapacitated him and put him in the care of Yama."

The other Maries sitting at the table, who had been scarcely paying attention, all perk up at the mention of that foul demon. "Yama? You do mean the Shadow, correct? Isn't he the Second Emperor in your stream?"

I can't help but grimace. "Yes. Of course, we all know he's seismically more powerful than the current First Emperor, which is why I hesitate to even attempt a rescue mission of Jason 12F."

The other Maries quickly grow bored again, leaving me to only speak with the first one. "You know our policy. Travelers never interfere with Source universes. That cannot be broken."

"I'm aware. At the least, I'd like if I could have amnesty while I seek out a method to stop this Jason."

"I'd like a lot of things, but I don't break the rules to get what I want." The other Marie rolls her eyes at me. "Oh well, I suppose if you need to hide for a while, we can allow it, but your actions will be very restricted. You are not to inquire about anything in the Primary Stream. It might destroy the multiverse if you did."

"You don't have to tell me twice." I smile politely. "Seriously, though. I need help."

"You're the one who thought a universe without war was possible. If you can manage such a crazy feat for as long as you have, I believe you will trounce this Jason."

Heh, she's not wrong. Creating a stable, peaceful universe was the hardest thing I've ever done. This new Jason will soon find out just how difficult it is to maintain peace without me there.

Part 412b: Maelgamish

I walk up to the door at my suite and pause to reflect on the day so far. Marie is gone for a little while, though to where, I don't know. I have free reign to change things as I wish, and she thinks she's going to bring back an elite squad to take me down unless I prostrate myself and lick her feet. That isn't going to happen.

I've been trying not to make any waves in the previous Jason's life, but that can't happen anymore. His existence was boring as sin. Other than a beautiful wife, he had nothing going for him. He was a pawn in Marie's plans, a puppet she pulled strings to make him dance. That isn't me, though. I'm not a hero for good, but I won't stand to watch a corrupt society that I have the power to fix. He let Marie do whatever she wanted, no matter the human cost. I will make humanity stand up for itself and evolve.

The door opens, and I walk inside, expecting to see Sarah. Instead, I see that same goddamn demon dog, now sitting on the other side of the room, observing my every move. He doesn't howl or growl at me, but his many eyes follow me as if he's waiting for me to slip up. Seriously, how did anyone decide that having a monster like this in the house was a good idea?

"Nice doggy... is Sarah home?" I take a few steps to position myself behind the kitchen counter, and the house's female AI speaks up.

"Sarah Hiro is not at home presently. She is at Marcus Atkins residence until late tomorrow night."

I can't help but scowl. Damn. I wanted to relieve some tension, but now I can't. "Computer, who the fuck is this Marcus Atkins guy?"

The computer beeps soothingly. "President Atkins is the leader of the Alpha-Centauri sector, and one of Sarah Hiro's seven interim sexual partners."

Oh. He sounds important. Why does she have seven other lovers though? Aren't we married? Does marriage count for so little in this society?

Well, the more I think about it, the more it makes sense. Supposing humans lived for millions of years, 'til death do us part' wouldn't make much sense since dying would be so rare. It makes sense she would have many lovers, and I probably do as well.

"Computer, how many interim sexual partners do *I* have?"

The female voice doesn't even pause to consider it. "None."

WHAT?! This is an outrage! Disgusting! How does the most powerful man in the galaxy, the man standing at the top of the human hierarchy, not have two dozen women by his side at any given time?!

I have to collect myself for a few seconds, carefully keeping an eye on that mutt as he shifts slightly where he sits. Even as I ponder the previous Jason's complete lack of sexual conquests, memories flow into my mind. *Long work days, hours spent sitting at conference tables overseeing the smooth running of the human empire, never-ending work that threatens to engulf his very soul.* The man simply didn't have the time, since all he ever did was work.

Well, when I think about it in that way, everything clicks into place. Sarah doesn't have a lot to do when I'm not around, so I guess she flits from man to man while her husband burns the midnight oil. Heck, based upon the total lack of angry emotions I didn't feel from the previous Jason's memories when she told me she was heading over to President Atkins' place, it must have been something she did a lot, and he didn't mind.

More things bug me about this relationship, though. Why is she going over to this hot-shot's suite? He sounds important in the political world. It can't just be that she likes him for his personality.

"Computer, what are the names of every one of Sarah's interim lovers? Display their names and faces on the wall viewscreen for me."

The computer blandly does as I ask, and I stare at it, surprised by the results. Five men and... two women? But, curiously, with their biographies plainly visible, the pattern instantly emerges. Every single one of these people is a political leader that runs vast areas of the galaxy. I technically lead all of human-kind, symbolically and politically, but my primary focus is the Sol System, the heart of humanity, the final stronghold in the case of a mass invasion. These other people though, they command regions such as the Lirius system, the Sirius binary star cluster, Procyon, and many others.

Why, though? Sarah is an innocent soul, one who devours food sloppily in a way that would disgust a child. She acts like a child, thinking of herself only with no regard for others. I could see her wanting to have fun and get away from her dull, stiff-necked husband, but other than that there's no reason to target these powerful men and women. Something else is going on, and I'm going to get to the bottom of it.

Suddenly, to my side, the dog stands up, the movement happening so quickly that I jerk back slightly. I'm so tired of looking at this animal. It's hideous, terrifying, and doesn't belong here.

I glance around the room quickly. Timothy isn't here, since I can't sense any other minds on the same floor, nor the one below me.

"Sorry, beast, but I warned you your days were numbered." I take a step towards it, and it growls savagely at me. "I wasn't so much scared of you as what killing you would do to my relationship with Sarah. But now, I won't have to worry. I've thought of a great cover story!"

With a quick yank from my telekinesis, I yank open the door to the balcony, and then hurl the animal back, shoving it over the ledge as it yelps in fright. For a split second, I almost feel regret, but it fades away as quickly as it started.

"Goodbye, mutt." I walk over to the edge and watch its massive body flail as it falls over a mile down, passing the cloud cover to where I can't see it anymore.

I never liked that beast. When Sarah asks, I'll just play innocent, and act as if he fell off the ledge. Maybe someone kidnapped the terrifying four-legged monster. I don't care, but now that he's gone, I can breathe a little easier.

"Ah, it's you. I wondered." A masculine voice speaks up behind me, and I leap in fright and spin to face him. To my surprise, the face is one I've seen before.

"Beelzebub? What are you doing here?!"

The Third Demon Emperor yawns mightily and blinks at me. "Saving one of my precious puppies. Luckily I heard its scream of terror and saved it just in the nick of time." He tilts his hand to the right, and I realize the hellhound is standing beside him. I had been so startled by Beelzy's appearance that I missed it entirely.

"That... that *thing* is yours?! What is it doing in my house, and why does everyone accept it so easily? It's a monster!"

"Calm down. It's just a hellhound. The only reason it doesn't like you is that it bonded with the former Jason, and not yourself. That was an oversight on my part. As for why everyone accepts it so easily, that is because what you see is not what everyone else sees."

Beelzebub nods at me, as if he explained everything perfectly. I wait for him to elaborate, but he doesn't. "What is it that everyone else sees?"

"An ordinary dog, a Black Labrador to be exact. You have been joined with Blaarjiim and were touched by the spirits of many demons during your stay in Hell. Only you can see through the disguise of this animal."

"Oh. That explains why Sarah seems to think he's a fluffy puppy. I wish I could look at him the way she does, except I can't help but feel like he's going to tear me apart."

Beelzebub nods. "I see your point. In any case, this hound was here in order to monitor the goings-on of the previous Supreme Commander. If you'd like, I can remove her from your residence."

"Her?"

"Yes. She is female." Beelzebub tilts his head slightly to glance at the dog's underside. "I think."

"Well, if I can be on friendly relations with the animal, err, *Skippy*, then I suppose she could stay-"

Beelzebub interrupts me. "Excuse me, but did you just call her... *Skippy*?"

"Well, the other Jason named her, so that wasn't my idea."

Beelzebub rolls his eyes. "Her proper name is Maelgamish. Devil's sake, you humans ruin everything you touch."

"You're telling me. Anyway, I'll keep her here, if you prefer. At least now things are clicking into place. You're not spying on *me* though, are you?"

Beelzebub blinks in surprise. "Quite the contrary. I have heard about today's killing of Benjamin Brown, however. A contact inside of Heaven was quite surprised when he told me the news; then I found out about the splashes you've been making. I trust these will not affect demon-kind?"

The moment of truth. Frankly, I owe the demons little to nothing. I don't like the vile ways they operate, but humans have their own issues. I have to focus on my species first before I even think about what comes next for the demons.

"We will see."

Beelzebub doesn't even bat an eye. "I'd say you are full of surprises, but somehow this is precisely the response I thought you'd give. Be warned that if you fight the demons, you will also have to fight Yama. I have witnessed Yama's power only one time, and that event was all the incentive Marie needed to convince humanity's leaders not to press the demons any further."

I lean against the wall behind me. "Sounds serious, what happened?"

"He killed three billion humans in six hours. The resulting souls that poured into him increased his power even further, and he threatened to tear civilization apart. I'll spare you the details."

Yeah, I wouldn't want to know precisely what happened, no way. Still, Yama sounds like a living doomsday device. I can't underestimate him. Three billion people? That's almost half the population of Earth back when I froze myself.

"Yama sounds mighty, but isn't he just the Second Emperor? What about Bael? Bael is the First Emperor, so isn't he much stronger?"

"I wonder about that sometimes myself." Beelzebub sniffles slightly and pats the black demon dog on the head. "I will leave Maelgamish in your care. I took the time to properly bond her to you, so she will not be hostile anymore."

"That desperate to avoid the question, huh? Well, whatever. By the way, be sure to let Yama know that Marie is aware of the stasis container that holds the previous Jason. I would like to have it in my possession, if possible."

"You think you can protect it more effectively than Yama? Impossible. The instant anyone sets foot in his domain their life is forfeit as he chooses. It will stay with him and will be quite safe."

For some reason, this pisses me off. "That guy is effectively me. This isn't about being safe or not safe; I want control of his body. Tell Yama I'll be there to pick it up soon, and that's the end of it."

Beelzebub's eyes harden. "Stealing from Yama is inadvisable."

"It's not stealing if the thing I'm taking doesn't belong to him."

"The Supreme Commander's body doesn't belong to you either, human." Beelzebub suddenly looks almost as pissed as me. I take a step forward, then pull back.

"Just give Yama the message. We'll settle this when the time comes."

"I hope you won't later regret that decision, Jason. Have a pleasant evening."

Beelzebub vanishes a moment later after making a motion with his hands. His departure is so abrupt that I'm left staring at where he was standing for a second or two until I turn my attention to the hellhound. She stares back at me, her tongue flopping out of her mouth as she pants slowly.

"Oh, don't you even *try* to look cute, you ugly mutt."

"Awrrr?"

Part 413b: Lineage

The texture of the bland nutrition bar crunches in my mouth tastelessly, like the thousands of others that came before it. I never counted how many I've eaten; they just became a fact of life at some point. By the time I was barely out of diapers, around age thirty or so, I had consumed so many of these bars that I no longer considered them food. The bars are just representative of life in modern society. Empty, lifeless, tasteless, dull.

When the tallies are counted someday, this will just be another one of my morning rituals, one I must perform to get myself ready for each day. Sometimes, once upon a blue moon, when my parents aren't around, and I am spending time with my friends, they will sneak a piece of 'real food' out. A few years ago, my friend Richard and I split an apple in three with Wendy, one of my classmates. The taste was intoxicating. All of us cried for several minutes afterward, because the taste was so heavenly.

I've forced myself to avoid food since then. If I continue eating regular food, it will only make these ritualistic nutrition bars much less appealing, given time. And, as everyone knows, 'real food' is so hard to come by. It's only going to get worse, as humanity continually expands, consumes more power, and spawns more children. More people, less power to go around, less chance of ever getting real food.

A door opens, and I lift my head up from the pad on the table in front of me. My father yawns as he steps out of his room, wearing only a robe. It's the most casual I've seen him dress in years. He's been acting very strange, lately. Well, not that I'm complaining. I feel that he's easier to talk to than normal.

"Oh, Timothy. When did you get here?" He strolls over to the kitchen counter and pours himself a glass of water, then smiles at me. *He smiles...* I can't remember ever seeing my father smile. It's a scary look, yet also warm and disarming at the same time. I'm conflicted about how to feel towards him.

I decide not to smile and instead nod politely. "I arrived about two hours ago. I was just studying for my bio-weapon and nano-technology exam, and couldn't get any quiet in the dorms. If you'd like, I can leave..."

He raises an eyebrow. "Not a chance, stay in that seat. Have you had breakfast yet-?" He spots the nutrition bar in front of me and scrunches up his face. "Ah, that won't do. You're the son of the Supreme Commander! You must eat healthily. After all, you're better than the other kids out there."

Hah... healthy. Father made me food yesterday... it was so good that it took all of my self-control not to weep tears of joy in front of him. I wanted to refuse, if only because I knew it couldn't last, but now he's talking as if eating the food of eons past is something we can do every day.

"This bar is fine, father. Thank you for the offer, though."

He curls up his lips in disgust. "Bacon. Eggs. Pancakes. Syrup. Waffles." Speaking five singular words, once again a massive amount of food pops into existence before him on the kitchen counter.

Magic.

It shouldn't be possible. Father has never once in all my life demonstrated the capability to do anything involving magic, yet here he is now, using it as naturally as if he'd been a master wizard his whole life. And what powerful magic it is, making something pop into existence from the nether! It defies logic and reason.

The food proceeds to hover in the air and land on the table beside me. He smiles and winks. "Now *that's* a breakfast. Go on, dig in."

The smell of foods I've never even heard of wafts into my nostrils, and I have to pull back slightly due to its intense aroma. What are these things on the plates before me? Something made of meat? *Meat*? Isn't that outlawed? Something circular resembling bread, but with holes all over in a criss-cross shape, and a stack of round saucer-like bread... I can't even describe it in words.

"Father, what is this?"

My question gives him pause as he sits down beside me. "It's breakfast. Real breakfast. Haven't you eaten anything like this before?"

My lip starts to tremble, and I turn to look out the window, away from his gaze. "N-no... of course I haven't. F-father, this food is... it... it would cost thousands of energy credits to replicate. Even the wealthiest people couldn't afford to eat like this..."

I flinch as his hand suddenly rests on my shoulder. "Timothy... it's okay." His deep voice is filled with reassurance, and I turn to look back at him in surprise. "Look, I've never really been there for you, right? I've come to see that I haven't valued my family enough. I want to start fixing society. I want to make things better, lead humanity into a better future. A good meal is integral to our lives as humans. Without a tasty treat, life isn't worth living."

I can't speak for several seconds, and finally, I have to reach up to wipe at my eyes. He pulls his hand away, and I hear a hint of something dark in his voice. "Are... are you crying?"

"What? No! Definitely not! There was- this lint got in my eyes! I just-!" I start babbling uncontrollably and start to pull back my chair so that I can get away from him, but he laughs loudly and makes me stop talking.

"Haha, oh jeez! If you're crying because the food is delicious, that's only natural. It is not only acceptable but better for you as a person if you release those emotions sometimes. All I ask is that you wait to cry until *after* you've eaten the food. It's getting cold."

He nudges the plate of seared meat to me, and I nod dumbly before reaching over to pick up one of the thin, wafer-like sticks. "What is this?"

"Bacon. It's made from a pig. Delicious."

A pig? I've never heard of such a creature. I slowly stick the bacon in my mouth and bite down, and the juicy, salty taste floods my senses instantly. Seconds later I stuff another piece in my mouth, and another, and another... this 'bacon' is so good! I've never tasted anything like it before in my life!

I have to pause to control myself, and when I look at my side, my father smiles again. "Looks like you know the truth, now, kid."

"Thank... you..." I can barely whisper as I stick a chunk of the breaded food in my mouth. Every new taste is a whole new experience, a fantastic blast of feelings I've never felt before in my life.

Minutes pass, and at one point I finish everything off and stare in disappointment at the empty plates. All that's left is some sweet 'syrup' on a plate, and I'm half-tempted to lick the plate clean. I'm not nearly full yet.

"Bacon." Father speaks a single word again, and a small plate-full of the meat appears on the table again. "Go ahead, have some more. It costs us nothing."

I take him on his offer breathlessly, stuffing the delicious pig-meat sticks in my mouth as he nods approvingly. Once I'm finished, I lean back and sigh in relief. This time, I'm full.

Father leans back in his chair and stares out the window to the dozens of megascrapers and stratoscrapers in the distance. Today is a typically beautiful, cheerful day, but the look of the metal world outside always makes me feel a little sad. I can't put the reason why into words, but I feel as if something that makes me *human* is missing.

"Timothy. Why is there so little food to go around?"

I pause for a moment to consider his question. "Do you not know, father?"

"This is a pop quiz. Snap to it, boy."

I nod quickly, remembering his strong desire for my education. I should have expected something like this. "Marie and yourself, uh, you created the food recycling system to conserve power. Due to the vast amount of land required to grow food for a population ballooning into the tens of billions, Marie decided to eliminate animal products, as they were incredibly wasteful. Later, she began the food recycling program once even pure vegetarian diets weren't enough to keep up with human consumption. Replicators were an early option, but due to the threat of war with the Volgrim, as much power as possible was diverted to the military, so their warships could be built and maintained, along with the warp-gates to other dimensions."

I cringe, thinking I might have missed a few details. My father nods thoughtfully to himself. "Yes, yes. Hmm... what does the military spend their energy credits on, primarily?"

Oh, shoot. I'm not well educated on matters of the military. If I mess up here, he's sure to notice, but I have to try my best. "They mostly spend their credits on maintaining the warp reactors aboard every ship, as well as... triferrium production? I think so, anyway."

He looks back at me. "You *think*?" He doesn't let the question hang in the air. "A good enough answer for now. Here is another; suppose that someone wanted to acquire food like what we've eaten here. How could they do so?"

"I'm not certain, father. I assume they would save up their energy credits for a long time. It might take several years, but with patience, they could afford a family meal." I pause and remember my friends, Richard and Wendy. "Well, if they wanted to risk imprisonment, the black markets would also be an option."

"Black markets?" His eyes widen slightly. "Go on. What about them?"

"Well, I barely know anything about them... but I know you can get food and other things. They're illegal, of course."

"Illegal, huh?" He smiles at me approvingly, and I breathe a sigh of relief. I was worried I might accidentally betray my friends. "Well, you should keep yourself safe and stay away from something as dangerous as a black market. I'll have to look into them, though."

Father finishes off his glass of water and stares at his upturned palms thoughtfully. "Yes. There is a lot I need to fix. Everything is wrong, upside down."

Minutes pass, and I hear a scratching at the back door. When I walk over to it, I cringe as that ugly black Labrador wants inside. I never liked it, but it is father's favorite pet, after all. I pull open the door and step back quickly, letting him trot inside. Father looks over at the animal and me.

"Oh, you let Mulgumiss in, huh?"

I tilt my head slightly. "Mulgumiss?"

The dog walks over to my father, and he pats it on the head slowly. "Or was it Mulfergiss? Milgruss? Mishmash?"

"Are you talking about Skippy, father?"

He shakes his head and stands up at the table abruptly. "Oh, don't mind me, just thinking out loud. I'm going to take the dog for a walk today. Have a good time at school."

"Have a good day too." I stop and watch as he walks with the dog outside, both of them disappearing behind the door as it closes.

He acts so oddly, lately.

* * *

The massive demonic animal sits beside me as we ride the hover-shaft down, and now she no longer stares at me suspiciously or acts like she's going to rip my throat out. I think Beelzebub did something to make her calm down and trust me, which is good, as I don't fully trust her yet.

"Hey, dog. What's your name again?"

I look down at her, and she pants as she gazes back at me. No response, of course. Dogs can't talk.

Well, under normal circumstances, they can't. But what if I gave her the ability to do so? "**Speak.**"

She continues panting and staring at me, with that scary face but also an adorable expression. It's a nail-biting contrast.

" **Sentience. Intelligence.** "

I speak two words, and a moment later she pulls her tongue back in her mouth. "Alright, I'm articulating my thoughts. What do you want to hear me say?"

I take a step back in surprise. I thought she might talk, but I didn't expect the process to be so easy. Her voice is somewhat high pitched, yet also a little growly, since her doggy vocal cords can't form the words perfectly.

"I don't know. I just wanted to find out your name since I forgot it already."

She lifts her paw up and licks it delicately. "How uncivilized. I am a majestic beast, born in the heart of the demonic empire and trained to be the perfect companion, a guard animal capable of tearing even the most fearsome home invader to shreds. My name was given to me personally by the Third Emperor, and I treasure it above all others."

Listening to the dog speak fluently and even in a regal manner is somewhat surreal. The hover-shaft's display tells me that we're only a minute away from arriving at the bottom floor.

"So what's your name?"

She stops licking her paw to stare through the glass floor at the surface of the Earth, far below us. "Grr, I suppose it's Maelgamish. It has been a while since anyone bothered to address me properly, but I believe that is what Emperor Beelzebub called me yesterday."

"You don't even remember?"

She tilts her head up to glare at me with all twelve of her eyes. "Oh, come on. I'm a hellhound. You're supposed to be the smart one here."

"Uh, good point I guess." The hover-shaft slows down as our floor approaches. "Don't speak when others are around. It'll cause both of us a lot of trouble."

"I said you were smart. I didn't say I was a *buffoon*." All of her eyes roll at the same time, and the door opens. I step off along with her, and a young man and woman wearing cadet uniforms spot Maelgamish and I. "The Supreme Commander, wow! What a beautiful dog!"

Maelgamish doesn't miss a beat. "Thank you." She turns and speaks directly to them, making both of them cock their heads.

I want to kick this mutt. "It's ventriloquism. Haven't you two ever heard of it?"

The girl nods slowly at me, though her expression shows she isn't convinced. "Ah... you're talented in a variety of ways, sir."

I walk quickly past them and grumble quietly to myself. Once we're around a corner and out of earshot, I nudge the mutt with my foot. "The heck was that for?"

"Payback for throwing me out of a window."

"Oh. That's fair."

I don't press the issue, and neither does she. When we pass another group of people, she woofs dumbly at them, and they just smile and wave.

Many minutes pass, and I arrive at the designated meeting place where I told Benjamin to meet me yesterday, a small resting facility where people can eat food and socialize. Naturally, he's already sitting at a table, minutes ahead of time, chewing a nutrition bar without the slightest interest in its taste. His fingers glide across the screen of his holopad, but without looking up, he speaks to me. "You're on time."

"I am." I sit down across from him, and Murglfish sits next to me and looks at the nutrition bar in his hand, all while licking her lips.

It takes him a few seconds, but eventually Ben sets the holopad on the table and yawns. "Alright, you're the boss. What are we doing today?"

"I want to know about the black markets. Can you tell me anything?"

Ben grabs a cup of coffee in front of himself. "Sure. I can tell you plenty. We've been tracking their actions for thousands of years, millions, even. Marie never interfered with the black markets though, since she calculated it would cause us more problems hindering them than letting them do their business."

"So you let people do illegal things with no consequences? That sounds like a recipe for disaster."

Ben shakes his head and sips his coffee. "Not at all. We prosecute anyone caught using the black market, and we shut down smaller, independent actors who try to start up their own markets. However, we don't actively chase down leads about who runs the bigger markets."

"It sounds like you're just letting the rich people get away with grand crimes. Why would you do that?"

Ben runs his fingers through his slicked-back hair. "Marie values competence. The black market goes against the grain of what she stands for, but they help keep humanity pacified. If people aren't uprising to fight back, or they aren't organizing protests and resistance to complain about how boring their lives are, then that's just fine by our standards."

"Some things never change. This black market is corrupt. Why don't we seize the food and supplies they offer and give it back to those who are deserving? Better yet, why don't I just use my wordsmithing to make unlimited food for everyone?"

Ben pulls back from me and laughs, sloshing the coffee around in his cup. "Haha! You're a funny guy, Jason! If you said 'food' over and over every minute of every day, you couldn't possibly maintain the energy to create enough food to feed even one percent of humanity. Reconditioned food is our only option." He polishes off the cup and shakes his head. "Marie has already thought about these matters. The only realistic solution you could do is create more energy-generating devices to power replicators to feed all of humanity. However, if we had access to that kind of energy, it would be smarter to give the energy to the military so we could prepare for a Volgrim incursion."

The Volgrim. Everyone says they're the scariest thing in the universe, aside from humanity itself, but I have no memories from the previous Jason's perspective involving a war where they crushed us.

"You say we need to prepare our military and devote as much energy to them as possible, but why? What threat does the Volgrim pose to a society that has a Wordsmith at its apex, a vast military, and a super genius? Not to mention the angels are our allies, and I'm guessing they would be necessary for a war too."

Ben nods and sets his empty cup down. "Things are never as simple as they seem, Jason. The Volgrim only hold a slight disadvantage against us when it comes to technology, and a larger one when it comes to population numbers and growth, but Marie has sources that tell her the Volgrim are hiding their real potential. They may have one or more super-weapons we know nothing about, since we never enter their territory."

"Yeah, Marie sure has many mysterious sources alright." I stand up from my chair, and Ben does the same. We both start walking out of the dining area and back into the main corridor, heading for an unknown destination. I just feel like walking. "So there's a black market, a silent alien threat, demons we can't kill off for political reasons, corruption, awful food, and plenty of other things I don't even know about yet. Does humanity do *anything* correctly these days?"

"Life might be boring, but it's also quite safe and relaxed too." My dog speaks up, making Ben take a quick step back. A look of surprise washes over his face.

"Saint Joseph, did that mutt just speak?!"

"I'm not a *mutt*, I'm a pretty princess." Milkmarsh sticks her tongue out at him cutely. "Have some manners."

Ben turns to me questioningly, and I shake my head. "Demon dog. I made her sentient and gave her the ability to speak. Don't question it, just play along."

"If you insist." He points out of a window towards a nearby stratoscraper. "Let's go to the shipyard. I have something I want to show you."

"I can't wait."

Part 414b: Fifteen

Ben and I arrive on a spaceship he owns, and after twenty minutes, we soon start cruising down to Earth's lower surface. The sun begins to darken as we pass through a thick haze that hovers over the ground.

Ben flicks a dial and the screen changes from a camera-based display to a wire-frame mode outlining buildings and other ships as we fly past them. "The smog down here is awful. I try not to go to the surface unless I absolutely have to."

"That bad, huh?" I slump back in my seat and relax while he expertly pilots us through dense hover-traffic that spans the vertical and horizontal axis as far as my eyes can see. "Sure are a lot of people flying around."

Ben shakes his head. "Maybe one in ten of these ships has a human inside. Most of them are automated. Drones to deliver goods to and from the surface to the stratoscrapers above. Only a quarter of Earth's population lives in the Shit Zone."

"By 'Shit Zone', you mean the smog?"

He pulls a hard left to turn us around a particularly tall skyscraper. "Yeah. It thins out the higher you go, but it's thick enough to make you gag if you go anywhere near the ground. Only the truly desperate live there."

A few seconds pass as I let him concentrate on bobbing and weaving through a particularly bad cluster of traffic. "Why are we going to the surface?"

His brow furrows in thought, and he glances at me for a second before looking back to the screen. "I love Marie, you know. I always stand by her decisions, no matter what. However, even I think Marie has flaws. She doesn't care much, if at all, about the lower-class citizens of the Human Empire. If you're serious about changing things for the better, the best shot you've got is seeing what it's like down here."

I smile smugly at him. "I guess even Marie has her faults, eh? I didn't take you to be the caring type."

"You don't know me very well. As I said before, Marie hired me because I'm a 'people person'. My job is to communicate her will to others who can't understand her genius."

The ship slows, and a docking bay opens up, swinging outward to let us land. "Uh huh. So, what, you want to feed the poor, save the children? Marie wouldn't do it, so now you're going to show me the worst side of society and hope I do?"

Our small ship autopilots its way into the hangar, and Ben sighs and bows his head. "Marie was always going out of her way to keep the other Jason limited. She never did anything that would allow him more freedom than necessary. Since it's clear that you won't be controlled like him, your Wordsmithing could be put to use fixing the elements of society that he couldn't, or wouldn't. It's up to you if you do."

"I'll think about it."

The display switches back to camera mode and a small crew of men and women appear on-screen. "Flight 4815, you are cleared for up to sixteen hours of docking time. Please deposit two hundred energy credits, and you may get on with your business."

Their polite but constrained tone makes me wonder to myself questioningly if they have anything against Ben, or perhaps just visitors from the upper districts in general.

After he follows the prompts on his screen and deposits the credits, he smiles jokingly at me. "It's on me this time, but you'll owe me two hundred credits if we come down here again."

"Sounds fair." We walk to the exit hatch in the back of the ship, squeezing through a narrow passageway in the process, and I ask him questioningly, "Can't I just Wordsmith energy credits?"

He groans. "Cheapskate."

It didn't answer my question, but the answer will have to do.

Molegrass pops out of a small hatchway behind us, grumbling to herself the whole time. "I can't believe you stuffed me in that tiny little box."

"Shut up, dog. Say one word in front of anyone down here, and I'll neuter you myself."

She whimpers and nods in response. Just in time, too, as a group of people walks past us. She'd better not think I'm joking, or this time I'll throw her off a ledge, and I won't mess up.

Ben looks at me for a moment before turning away. "You stick out like a sore thumb. Everyone knows what the Supreme Commander looks like, down in the slums. Even if they don't, you're dressed in high-ranking military garb. You won't find anyone willing to talk to you if you look like that."

"Easily fixed." The three of us walk behind a console out of sight from everyone else. "**Disguise. Clothes.**" My professional suit changes into something much plainer looking, as does Ben's, and I even alter my face to look like my normal self, removing the beard along with it. "How about that?"

He snickers. "You have a real baby face under all that fur. Nobody's gonna recognize you like that."

"Yup, that's me, Baby Face Nelson. Let's hurry up and get this over with."

* * *

Half an hour later, Ben and I walk across a catwalk surrounded by dingy, brown glass. If I squint and look closely, I can see the air outside slowly swirling around us, which reminds me of milk spilled into a vat of black food coloring. Every so often, the three of us pass by poor downtrodden souls. They never look up at me, never beg for money as people would in the world I came from, and simply mosey on about their business.

The smell in the air is thick, almost acrid. It's a smell that causes me to remember gas stations from the past, and it makes me not want to light a match for fear of blowing everything up. The air inside the buildings is clean enough, and the temperature is about perfect, all things considered, but the odor almost gags me. Nobody around us seems to mind; they're probably long since used to it.

"What is that smell? How does all of this smog exist in such an advanced society?"

Ben scratches his throat and frowns. "Well, the facilities that recondition food in masses burn fuel of different sorts. Nowadays everything is powered by fusion, fission, or solar energy, but that wasn't always the case. Most of the smog is leftover from the ancient times, millions of years ago. Marie didn't want to waste energy cleaning up a dead planet, and it was already too late by the time she'd thought of technology that could reverse it."

"The Earth is dead? How so?"

He waves his hand at the world past the glass. "You think animals can live in this? If any mammals or amphibians or anything else is alive aside from bugs, they're horribly mutated creatures, disgusting to look at. Vegetation still exists, but much of it is moss and fungus. Trees have long since choked and died." He sighs and pauses to stare at the brown air swirling around. "Yep... the Earth is toast. Humans killed it."

I stop to take a breath. "I can't believe it. All the animals are dead, all the greenery... Marie just let this happen?"

Ben quickly shakes his head. "Oh no, I didn't explain everything yet. Animals and plants are still alive, on Martian nature preserves, and other planets throughout the galaxy. Rygar, for example, is a world where we migrated 60% of Earth's remaining species around thirty million years ago. Humans aren't allowed to set foot there, aside from the 4,000 scientists who spend their days preserving the lives of those animals." He waves a finger around. "Not only that, but they preserve genetic differences and keep the animals the same over time, allowing new species to form only after applying for permits. It's a whole process, very fascinating. Earth is completely dead though."

"Oh. That's better than I expected." Indeed, I thought all the elephants and polar bears were gone. At least there's some comfort that even if Earth is dead, it lives on, its inhabitants spread all over the galaxy. Humanity is in no danger of an imminent extinction event.

We continue walking, and Muttwiggle nudges my hand with her nose. Nobody is around, so she whispers. "Pardon me, but I'm hungry."

I glance at Ben, and he shrugs. "I'm good. I had coffee."

I ate too before I left. I shoot a glare at the dog. "Well, you'll have to deal with it. Should have eaten before we headed out."

She mumbles something under her breath that sounds vaguely like a curse word, but I ignore it.

Ben nudges me. "We're here. This is the bar where most low-level workers hang out after their shifts are over."

He points at a metal doorway nestled in a wall. The door has indentations shaped like letters pounded into it. *Thompson's Bar and Grill*.

I look at Ben inquisitively, and he shrugs. "This place is old, really old. It's been around forever. Heck, I even used to eat here, before they stopped serving normal food. Nowadays it's one of the few places in the lower levels where you can get nutrition bars purer than 15% reconditioned quality."

He presses a button, and the door slides up into the ceiling, making a quick gear-grinding noise as it does.

The room inside is dimly lit. Smoke fills the air, and I cough reflexively, but Ben doesn't mind at all. "You'll get used to it."

I hope so. We take a seat at a table and Ben waves at a waitress. Rather than coming over and taking our order, she just nods and walks into the back. A moment later she walks out, holding two nutrition bars wrapped in foil and two ceramic cups full of coffee. After setting them down at our table, she scurries away without a word.

"Polite lady, isn't she?" I pull the coffee toward me and sniff it. It smells like shit. I hate this stuff. The nutrition bar isn't doing me any favors either.

"There isn't much to say. All the nutrition bars here are free, provided by the government. This place is considered a cultural hub, so they give it some exclusive benefits. She isn't paid anything, just does this to pass the time." Ben sips the coffee and smacks his lips. "Man, that's the good stuff."

I don't see what's so good about bitter brown swill, but to each their own. My eyes pass over the crowd to a few guys playing a game I recognize off in the back, away from the other diners. Billiards. A short guy with a scraggly beard and a limp in his step lines up the cue ball and rockets it off the 9-ball, smacking it into a side pocket. The cue ball rolls back to almost the same position from where he started, and he shoots again, sinking the 13-ball after, only for the cue-ball to move right back to where it started.

The other two men shake their heads in defeat as he picks off the balls, one by one. Once he's done, he drops the 8-ball in and smiles as the cue-ball rolls back to where he started. "That's ten points for me. Quite the deficit, wanna double or nothing?"

As he stuffs his hands in his pockets, the other two guys shake their head. "Nah, you win this 'un, Edgar." Both of them press a button on their datapads and walk back to their table and sit down.

Edgar seems satisfied with his winnings, but disappointed the other guys walked away so quickly. A moment later, he spots me looking at him and winks. With a hop in his step, he waltzes over to my table. "Evenin', sirs! How'd you like to play a friendly game of Fifteen?"

Ben grunts and shakes his head. "No thanks, son. We're just having a friendly chat, that's all."

Edgar seems miffed that Ben won't even look at him, but a moment later there's a spark of recognition in his eyes. "Hey, wait a second, you look familiar! Yeah, yeah! I recognize you!" He shakes his finger as he struggles to find the name on the tip of his tongue. "That's right; you're Benjamin Brown! I'd recognize you anywhere!"

Ben shoots a look of annoyance at me. *Great, so much for going incognito.* His expression betrays his thoughts, though I can also read them thanks to my telepathy.

"Um, yes. Do I know you though?" Ben glances up at the guy and quickly shakes his head. "I remember most faces, but not yours."

"Nah, but that's okay!" Edgar grabs a chair and yanks it out, then plops down at the edge of the table, between Ben and me. With a practiced movement, he reaches down and pets our dog without actually looking at it. "You're a famous guy 'round here! You were just like us, a bottom dweller who busted your ass and made it out of this shithole! And you killed a whole lot of demons while you were at it, too!"

Ben grunts and mutters something under his breath, but I don't quite catch it. He opens his mouth to say something, but suddenly his eyes shift to meet mine, and I can feel a thought pass through his mind. *Hey, this guy could be useful.*

He smiles suddenly, far more than I expected, and gestures at me. "Ah, I forgot to mention, I'm here with my grand-nephew, Jasper. He was born and raised in the upper levels, so I wanted to show him around the lower levels. He's a bit of a privileged kid, see."

Edgar swivels to me. "Great! Good to meet you, kid! Your grand-uncle's a stand-up guy!" He thrusts a hand forward, and I quickly shake just to get him away from me. Already the stench of alcohol is hissing from the edge of his mouth and making our table stink. He immediately forgets I'm even here and turns back to face Ben. "Aren't you working at the upper levels now for bigshots? I heard you were in private security!"

Ben smiles, but I sense a lot of discomfort from him. "Yes, uh, something like that. You really keep up to date on my status, mister...?"

"Aw, shucks. I got so excited that I forgot to introduce myself! I'm Edgar Boris, gamblin' extraordinaire and flamboyant ladies-man, yessir! Though I make my money now by winnin' *honest* games of Fifteen these days." The way he enunciates 'honest' makes me suspect he's a little less forthcoming than he pretends to be.

I decide to poke my way into the conversation. "Say, what if we play against you in your favorite game for a friendly bet? I have some questions about life down here in the lower levels, and you look like a pretty smart guy."

Edgar bows his head and blushes. "Aw, shucks. I ain't that smart. But I will whip you good in a game o' Fifteen! Come on, let's do this!" He hops up from the table and quickly walks over to set up the table.

Ben and I stand up to follow, and Ben nods at me. "You've got the same idea I do. He's a talker, might give you useful information."

"That's the idea." We walk over, and Edgar beckons to the balls he's just racked up. "Alright, I'll let you boys decide the order of play."

I speak before Ben can. "My grand-uncle will play first; you go next, then I'll finish."

"Mhm. What are we betting, Mister Boris?" Ben looks suspicious, and Boris makes a big show of hemming and hawing it over. "I dunno, what say maybe, ahhh, hmm... how about fifty energy credits, eh?"

I'm not sure how many credits 50 energy credits are worth, but Ben doesn't look like he'll lose too much sleep. "Yeah, that'll do. We'll just bet from my stash since Jasper doesn't have any credits in his... *allowance*." He stifles a snicker, and I resist the urge to punch him. He's enjoying treating me like a kid way too much. Though, to be fair, I am only 18, realistically. My time spent in the cryopod did nothing for me, so my mental age is approximately my real age.

Ben lines up a shot and slams the cue-ball into the 1-ball, smashing all the others apart and spreading them over the table. Luckily, the 13-ball goes in.

"That's a point for the both of you." Edgar looks perfectly happy that we've gained a point. He acts as if he has this game in the bag. We'll see about that.

Ben aims and manages just barely to knock the 6-ball into the far corner pocket. "I played quite a bit of Fifteen when I was younger." For a moment, I spot a look of smugness on his face, but he brushes it away. After lining up another shot, he fires it off and smacks the 1-ball, but it glances off the side hole and rolls away, the cue-ball sinking instead.

"You did, huh? Well, I'm glad you're takin' it easy on me. Two against one just ain't fair for a poor cripple like me." He slaps his ball on the table, lines up a shot, and misses catastrophically, then pretends to play it off. "Man, I must be tired from all those games I played earlier."

I nod at him and line up my shot. "So, Edgar, what are you planning to do with the credits you earn?" I sink the 2-ball in effortlessly, but miss my next shot, and it's back to Ben.

Edgar shrugs. "Well, I gotta get my leg fixed first. It's in real bad shape. Medical care is decent down here, but the premium stuff is for middle-level workers and up, so I'll probably have Four-Finger Freddy do somethin' for me. I've been earning favors from him for a while now."

Ben whistles aimlessly and fires his ball, hitting his target but missing the shot. It's three to zero, in our favor.

"Who's Four Fingered Freddy?" I ask the question casually as Edgar steps up to the table and lines up his shot. He sinks it casually and scrunches up his face when he looks at me.

"You ain't heard of him? Shit, he runs the market this side of the city. Nice guy, but real stern. You don't disrespect him, or you get a visit from his friends." Edgar leans back and pops another shot off, dropping another ball in. Score 3-2, our favor still.

"The market? You mean the black market?" I ask the question innocently, but I can feel a few people turning to listen to our conversation.

"Yeah, *sure*." Edgar suddenly looks annoyed as people glance over at him. "You can call it that, if you want. Ain't really accurate though. Everything they've got, they earn it legit. They offer medical services for people like me. They're heroes down here; I'll have you know."

Ben coughs as Edgar sinks yet another shot. Score 3-3, tied. "We understand. We're not prying or anything, just curious. It's been a long time since I lived down here."

"Yeah... a long time." The man hobbling around the table echoes Ben's words hollowly. Even though he suddenly seems more distant than before, he lands another shot without trouble.

Score 4-3, his favor. "You know, sometimes I wonder if it's even worth the trouble."

"What do you mean?" I've scarcely asked the question, and he slams another shot in, using a bit more power than the previous one. Score, 5-3, his favor.

"Oh, you know. The rat-race. I wasn't always poor. Had an adequate job in the middle sector for a while, but it felt like they had me pushin' buttons all day rather'n doin' anything useful." He takes aim and smashes the cue-ball again, but this time it glances off his intended target and rolls to the side, so he hands the stick to me. "Ended up losin' my position when I hit on a coworker. He didn't like me much, I reckon, so I had to sit down with upper management, and they fired me. Two hundred thousand years down the tube."

I sink a shot in, then miss the next one, bringing our score to 5-4, his favor. "Sounds rough. What's the alternate, then, if not working your way back up the ladder."

He snuffles and waits for Ben to take a shot next. "Oh, I just hate the smell down here, but I have lots of friends now, and more fun than I ever used to up top. I've been thinkin', ya know... what if I killed myself?"

He says it so casually, but Ben doesn't even flinch. I nod slowly. "Uh... you want to *kill yourself*? Seems a little extreme."

"Oh, sure. I get to be an angel, live somewhere clean. Of course, there are all the problems that come with that."

"Like what?"

Ben smacks two balls in with a single shot, then misses the next. 6-5, our favor.

"Well, you know how it is. Once you're an angel, you can't ever leave Heaven, 'cept if you get a permit or pay their ridiculous fee, which nobody can afford. Only people who die as high-level citizens ever get to come back, that's the way it is. Still, I'd maybe get to see my ex-wives again. If any of the gang dies after me, we can all hang out together. I'm just... torn."

He takes the stick and instantly lands one shot, then pivots around and knocks two more balls in at the same time. Score, 8-6, his favor. The last ball standing is the 8-ball, which he sinks without hesitation.

Ben chimes in with his thoughts. "If you're unsure of what to do, why not keep working your way up the ladder again, so when you get to mid-level, you can earn the energy credits to go visit your friends and wives who have passed? It'll take a long time, but you've got forever. It's not like you're going to die of old age."

Edgar chuckles. "Now that's a fine idea. You're a smart guy, Benjamin. No wonder you ended up at the top. Lot smarter'n me."

Ben shakes his head and looks at me, though his eyes seem to look past me, at the wall behind. "I'm not that smart... just a lucky guy in the right place at the right time."

Edgar nudges Ben in the arm with his fist. "I hear ya. You gents wanna have another go?"

"No, but that was fun. I know when my ass is chapped." Ben snickers and brings up his datapad, sending the energy credits over to Edgar. "Good talk though, you were a real help."

"Thank ya kindly for the credits, good sir. I'll be seeing you two around...?" Edgar trails his sentence off, but Ben shakes his head.

"No, I've got a lot of work to attend to." He nudges Edgar. "You know how it is, button pushing, busywork. I'm a little jealous of you."

"Pff, jealous of me. Funny guy." Edgar waves at us as we turn and walk away. I beckon to Moldrush, and she stands up and follows after us.

As we step outside, the door closes behind us, and I pause for a moment. "That Edgar guy has lived a rough life."

"Mhm." Ben shrugs. "Nobody's life is easy."

"Yeah, but, he's lost a lot of people, yet he's still trying to be optimistic."

Ben continues nodding. "Some people are just that way."

We start to walk again, but I pause and speak a single word to the air. " **Pill.** "

A small orange pill with liquid inside appears in front of me and lands in my hand. "One sec, Ben."

I turn back and walk inside, then find Edgar, now sitting at a table and staring off into space. When I tap his shoulder, he turns back to look at me and is a little surprised. "Oh, you're back! What's up? Want another whooping?"

I smile and shake my head. "No, not really. Here." I hold my hand in the air and drop the pill on the table in front of him.

He glances at it suspiciously. "What's this? Cyanide?"

"No. You're a good guy, Edgar. Take this pill, and I bet that foot will feel a lot better tonight."

He turns to look at me in surprise, but I'm already halfway out the door. Ben stares at me with a look of amusement. "What was that about?"

"Nothing in particular. Let's find that Four Fingered Freddy guy. He sounds like an interesting character."

Part 415b: Purity, Falsehoods

"King Zeus has returned!" I look up from a weekly report and listen as a palace guard yells out. All around me, other angels jump to their feet and bow at the waist, while I take a few seconds to stand up from my chair and bend only slightly. Zeus marches through the doorway, his kingly demeanor making all pause their breathing for a moment or two.

"Ah, Gabriel, there you are." Zeus walks over to me, so I stand back up to my full height of a few feet taller than him. "I've just returned from the Human Realm."

"You were gone a long time, my lord. Three days, by my count. How did your trip end?"

The other angels in the large room silently return to what they were doing. Here in the palace, only pure-bloods are allowed to enter, and while most of their duties are ordinarily ceremonial, those in the Holy Chamber are tasked with the job of maintaining order among ten trillion pseudo-angels and a hundred thousand pure-bloods. Merely counting their numbers for the twice-per-century census is a daunting enough task.

Zeus walks past me, and I follow behind him, the two of us entering the King's Hall, a room with a most splendid golden throne, gifted to our kind tens of millions of years ago by the leader of humanity, Jason Hiro, during his rise to power. Two massive golden wings spread out from the back of it, while the seat and backrest are covered with a dark maroon-colored padding, which Zeus has assured me is luxuriantly comfortable.

The king takes his seat and glances around at the currently empty Benches of Judgment, where ruling pure-bloods would be called to sit if an angel should need to be punished for crimes against his or her species. Luckily, those benches have not been used for eons, but still, they are faithfully dusted and cleaned every day by the lower-class pure-bloods.

"My trip went well, as always. Uneventful, even. I tried to inquire with the Supreme Commander about my proposal, but he was rather distracted. Well, now that I think about it, there was a rather grisly murder at the end of the meeting."

Zeus waves his hand flippantly. I wait for him to explain, but he doesn't continue. "A murder, my king?"

I lean back against a pillar to one side of the throne and Zeus sighs. "Ah, yes, you know how humans are. They haven't had a taste of murdering demons for a long time, and they've grown accustomed to peace, so naturally, they will quarrel with one another. It appears that one of the high-ranking humans on the council, Danis Thornum, a person I've only heard of in passing, was violently killed by a single decisive strike as he exited the War Council."

A feeling of alarm washes over me, and I pull slightly away from the pillar to advance a step towards Zeus. "A political assassination? You were in danger! How could the humans allow something like this to happen?! Where was the security? The respect for your life?!"

Zeus raises his hand. "Calm thyself. I am the King of Gods. It would require an organized human army to take me down, even when I am alone, especially given the energy treaty the humans signed. If they wished to kill me, they would be better served to cut off their prayers for a thousand years before launching said assault."

My aura changes and I soothe my ruffled feathers. "Apologies, my liege. I meant no disrespect to your awesome power. Speaking of that power...?"

Zeus sighs. "As I said, Jason Hiro would scarcely even look at me. If we could just get him to increase the human breeding speed by even a single percent, it would help speed the process considerably."

"Mmm. Still, a single pure-blood every thousand years is exemplary, Lord Zeus. I am impressed you figured out how to create more of my kind in the first place. You are a visionary among our people."

Zeus stands up from his chair and paces over to the gated window to stare out at the Towers of Heaven, human-built constructions that allow tens of trillions of half-breeds to live in relative peace, away from the ruling areas where we pure-bloods live. These buildings resemble the stratoscrapers that humans construct on their worlds, but with added flair to make them more palatable to gaze upon. The Towers of Heaven have softer, rounded edges, and offer many spaces for angels to fly at and land inside, since we do not need hovering vehicles as humans do.

"A visionary, perhaps. The angels have made many sacrifices and have had to lower the barriers for entry repeatedly to convince humanity of our goodwill, but the results are worth it. I remember a time when Angels were on the verge of extinction, back when our numbers were half as many as they are now. Can you believe how far we've come?"

I nod silently and walk over to stand beside him. On the palace steps outside, several angels are lounging and chatting amongst themselves, having fun. "We cannot be complacent, though, my king. Have you considered the Volgrim representative's request?"

Zeus chuckles. "I wouldn't trust a human as far as I could throw him, though admittedly I could hurl him quite a distance if I so desired. Even then, having to live off the energy of a deceitful species we know is still a better choice than living off one we do not. I will continue to refuse the Executor's offer unless our relations with the humans worsen substantially."

Zeus pauses to look at me meaningfully, his aged eyes hiding a great deal of wisdom. "The Volgrim's numbers are paltry compared to that of humanity. The only way we could survive is if

we purged the false ones from our ranks, and you know what Uzziel would say."

"What *would* Uzziel say?" A voice speaks up from behind us, and we both turn to locate its speaker. An old angel hobbles along, leaning on his cane, with a great bushy beard nearly touching the floor due to his slouched posture.

"Archangel Raphael, I'm happy to see you again! We haven't spoken in a few weeks, have we?" Zeus spins around to examine the ancient one, and Raphael coughs into his hand. "We were just discussing some conflict that erupted among the humans. There was some form of political assassination directed at one of their kind while I was visiting during official business."

Raphael nods and clutches his chest, then wheezes slightly as he pulls back to sit down on one of the Benches of Judgment. "That is troubling news, King Zeus. I-" He coughs again and continues talking. "...I was wondering what they might be up to since they have been holding war council meetings more often."

I interrupt Zeus before he can speak. "Are you still plagued by that cough, Raphael? You sound raspier than you were in the past."

Zeus nods. "Angels don't get sick, Raphael. Certainly not archangels. I've been asking around, but I can't find the source of what ails you. Feel free to solicit our aid if you need any assistance."

Raphael wheezes and smiles painfully. "Ahh, it's nothing, youngsters. I'm certain it's just old age, nothing to be concerned about."

"Hmm, but angels don't age in the way humans do. I find that hard to-" Zeus starts to say something else, but Raphael cuts him off.

"Cheh... I'm not dying, Lord Zeus, so have no concerns about my well-being. This too shall pass."

I share a glance with my king, but we both shrug. This ancient angel has his pride, so it's better to just investigate in secret. I turn back to Raphael. "As you wish."

Zeus swallows heavily. "On to more pleasant topics. In five more years, I will have amassed the energy required to create a new pure-blood. The last thousand years have been relatively peaceful, but I sense humanity is getting restless."

"Is this why you wish to increase humanity's energy output?" I ask the question and glance over at Raphael, who nods along silently.

Zeus clears his throat. "If I can make humanity increase their thought-energy output, I might be able to shave decades off the pure-blood creation time. Above all other things, though, we mustn't let humans know what we are using the energy for. They have no grasp of the scale of

our energy needs, so as long as we can maintain that illusion of a desperate energy need just to stay alive, they will not take us seriously."

Raphael shakes his head. "I had not thought my kind would ever resort to lies and trickery, but in truth, humanity's ability to eradicate us makes any military force we might exert rather meaningless." The old one raises a bushy eyebrow. "Though, this must be why you were speaking about a purge, hmm?"

Zeus and I both shift uncomfortably. I decide to answer Raphael's question. "Brother, you must understand... the fringe elements of human society have realized that a relatively cushy life awaits them in Heaven. I have seen a 5% increase just in the last decade of people killing themselves to ascend to Heaven. These low-level degenerates threaten Zeus's ability to create more pure-bloods. Every half-breed we're forced to admit is just a drain on-"

Raphael raises his face and glares up at me, an expression he rarely makes. "A drain, yes, but have you thought nothing of what is going on in the human's soc-" He pauses to hack into his hand before continuing again. "-the human's society? Because we make ever increasing demands for their birth rates, they are unable to keep up their food production and energy production. They are at a standstill with the Volgrim negotiations. They have been very generous with births up to this point, so why not simply have patience? We have all the time in the world to wait, and eventually, our kind will flourish once again."

Zeus licks his lips and turns his head back slightly to look out the window, even as he crosses his arms. "I respectfully disagree, Archangel Raphael. Your wisdom and ability to separate bias from both sides is always appreciated, but I do wish you would care more for your own species' survival. The lower elements of the pseudo-angel society contribute nothing, and merely consume our energy. They are an anchor we have willingly tied to our legs."

Raphael grimaces and stands up to walk away. "If the humans fall, we fall as well. Putting your trust in the Volgrim, while purging all the undesirables from our society... that is a recipe for disaster. What reason would the Volgrim have to trust us if we killed our previous hosts?"

Neither Zeus nor I respond, and merely watch as the old one shuffles out of sight, closing the great doors behind him.

The King of Gods turns to me and smiles half-heartedly. "He's not wrong. However, the Volgrim have a rigidly structured society. They understand law and order. They would be a sufficient backup if the worst were to happen."

"Perhaps." I look past Zeus, out the window, to the pure-bloods and half-breeds flying around between buildings in the distance. "I just like the way things are now. I wish they

wouldn't change. Peace, prosperity, no threat of a demon invasion, and no humans visibly ready to turn on us... this is what I have always wanted."

Zeus's smile solidifies, and he squeezes my shoulder. "Aye. Just remember; during the worst of times, stick to kin. You can always trust your own people."

"I can't disagree with that."

* * *

Ben and I stomp down the streets, having left the dog in the ship to eat at Ben's request. The sensation of hard pavement, something that would ordinarily make me feel closer to the world and time I came from, is slightly off. This pavement has a smoother feel to it, something Ben comments on when he spots me staring down at it.

"This texture you're feeling is E.A.T.S., which stands for 'Ecologically Activated Terrain System'. It's a surface that covers the ground of all areas outside of buildings at Earth's surface area. Nanobots build and maintain it regularly, preventing it from cracking or breaking as time goes on. A novel invention, though very few people step outside the glass-zones."

I glance above us. We're on the ground level, now, but humanity has created safe passages from building to building at the ground level, where we can walk through glass tunnels to get from one place to the next.

I bend over to rap my knuckles on it, but Ben grabs my arm. "I'd advise against doing that. E.A.T.S. devours biological contaminants on its surface."

I pull my hand back and curl my lips up. "That sounds rather dangerous."

He nods. "It keeps your shoes squeaky clean though, which is nice. Also, it makes for... rapid corpse removal."

I stop his momentum with my hand. "Hold on, are you telling me humanity just dumps dead bodies in the streets, and those corpses get devoured by nanobots?"

Ben sighs and looks up through the glass ceiling above us guiltily. "It's a little more delicate than that, but suffice to say, everyone is cautious not to fall when they're outside."

"Ben, this is the craziest thing I've heard since I arrived. Why would Marie create something that sounds like it could accidentally kill people?"

Ben smirks as he looks back at me. "You think this is an *accident*? Didn't I tell you? Marie doesn't care about the lesser performing lower educated dregs of society. If someone falls onto the pavement, then in her eyes, they're too stupid to live anyway."

I rub my forehead and feel sweat coat my hand. "That's harsh. I can't believe Marie would make something like this... does she just love the feeling of taking a life?"

We continue walking, and Ben flicks the glass to his side. "It's not like that, Jason. Remember, Earth's animals were dying off in droves thanks to pollution. Their bodies were everywhere, and gasses from their corpses contributed dramatically to global warming. Marie decided that once we moved the remaining population off the Earth and onto more suitable worlds, it would be best to terraform the Earth one last time... so she did."

His breath trails off. I wring my hands as many thoughts come to me. "So, you created this nano-road stuff to... coat the Earth? It devours all life though, including trees, grass, bugs..."

We finally reach the end of the walkway and enter a new building, and Ben purses his lips. "True, but those were all going to rot and fail, anyway. Once the bees died off, we were artificially prolonging Earth's inevitable demise. Marie just sped the process along and completed it. Now Earth houses humans, and us alone. Well, there are pets too, of course." He winks at me. "It's a good thing you didn't bring that cute dog along; she wouldn't be here anymore."

"That's disgusting."

He nods. "I never said I agreed with Marie's methods. I care for the lower citizens, but I understand her reasoning as well."

I pause to look around the skyscraper we've entered. Unlike the other buildings, this one looks old, ancient even, by modern standards. It appears to be a hotel, resembling a luxury 5-star building from my time, like a Hyatt or a Marriott. The floor is covered in exotic red and gold carpets, the walls are made of faded stone that would have once been perfectly chiseled marble, and pillars extend down from the ceiling that have all sorts of patterns visible in their granite veins.

As we step inside, a pretty girl walks up to us. Her hair is pulled back into a bun, and she's wearing a navy-blue short-sleeved shirt with a modestly lengthy skirt, both of which look like a uniform for this establishment. The sailor-style hat on her head reads *Prince Corps*.

"Hello, sirs, what can I help you find today?" Her voice is tight and measured, and she doesn't smile at all. She looks me up and down suspiciously, but doesn't appear concerned about Benjamin in the slightest.

He takes the initiative. "We're here to see Four Finger Freddy."

Her eyes light up, but she doesn't smile. "I trust you have a card, then?"

Ben and I turn our heads to look at each other before looking back to her. He shakes his head. "I'm new, didn't know I needed one."

"Everyone pays their membership dues. It's one hundred credits to purchase a member card." She eyeballs me again. " *Per person* who seeks to examine our wares."

Ben tries to hide his dismay that he has to lose even more credits, but it doesn't come off well. "Fine, I'll give two hundred credits for my nephew and I."

The girl instantly spins on her heel and marches away. "Follow me."

We walk for a few minutes, winding our way past the front desk, through several old fashioned handle-style doors, and up a set of stairs with at least twenty steps.

I decide to ask questions since my curiosity is getting the better of me. "How old is this place?"

"Old."

She doesn't elaborate, and her tone of voice tells me she isn't interested in chatting. *I like her.*

We stop in front of a plain brown door where a tall, wiry-looking man is standing outside. The girl looks at him and jerks her head back toward us. "New buyers. Here to see Freddy."

The guy at the door holds up a datapad. He sniffles and skulks about, making me think he's a very shift person. "S-so, you're here to see Freddy, eh? Show me the credits!" He scratches his arms nervously and keeps twitching, so I make sure to keep my distance. This guy is creepy.

Ben bites his lip as he pulls up his datapad, presses a series of prompts, and sends the credits over. "Done."

The skinny guy shivers. "Thank you, sir! Come on in; it's right through here!" He slaps his hand on a scanner, and the door unlocks, opening up for us to see inside.

We enter slowly, and the man closes the door behind us. Despite the fact that we were in a classical hotel before, this room is completely different. All around us are computer terminals, with signs above that say things like "general goods", or "food", or even "recreation". The floor is tiled with metal, and the cracks between each tile are barely visible.

Ben and I stroll into the room, noting the ceiling is a few feet higher than outside, and the room has been artificially enlarged to fit multiple giant monitors everywhere.

"Oh, people?" A voice speaks up, and to my surprise, a teenager walks around the corner from an adjoining room. His hair is messy but his clothing is impressive, and he wears a mink fur that drapes over both shoulders. "What are you two here for?"

This time, I push in front of Ben. I don't like that he's been getting ahead of me when we engage people. "We're here to meet Four Finger Freddy. We heard he runs the local black market."

"Uh huh. That's me." The kid holds up his right hand, and to my surprise, it has six fingers. A second pinky hangs off the end awkwardly, like it was glued on.

"You're the leader of this place? I didn't think you'd be... so..."

"Young, yeah. Everyone says that. Do you have your cards?" His features droop and his posture slumps even more. He's already bored of us, I can tell. "Wait, of course you do. Ty wouldn't let anyone in without them."

Ben speaks up. "Actually, we wanted to ask a few questions first. Some rumors are going around downtown that the government is cracking down on markets in the area. Is that correct?"

An obvious lie. Ben made it up just to sift for information. The kid doesn't seem to care. "Oh yeah, definitely. We're going out of business. Why, just for you fellas, I'll double the prices to prove it." He gives us a deadpan look and rolls his eyes. "No, the government doesn't care about us. They waste a million tons of serviceable food every day, just because if they tried to give it out, they would piss more people off than would be happy. We're glad to take a small portion of it off their hands." He walks over and taps on the food terminal. "Look at this; we've got fresh apples, oranges, bananas, chicken, even some steak." He pauses to look back at us. "Dunno what animal the steak came from, but it's meat, right?"

Ben makes a slurping sound with his mouth as he examines the food on the screen, but I lean back. The chicken makes me feel anxious. *Wait, is he going to buy something? I thought we were here to get information?*

Ben pokes an option on the screen. "One thousand credits for a single apple?! Are you running a scam?"

"Huh? It's two thousand. Don't you remember? I'm doubling the prices for you gents." Freddy shrugs. "Don't like it? Don't make fun of my intelligence, simple as that."

He paces over to a different computer, one marked 'Luxury'. After pressing a few options, he points at the screen and Ben gasps. "An unlimited two-way Heaven travel permit? Where did you get this?!"

The kid shrugs. "Things come and go. If you want it, it's only ten thousand energy credits. Well, twenty for you."

Ben scowls. "You're not doing a very good job convincing me that you want my business."

"That's because I don't care." Freddy walks away from the computer, pushing past me in the process, and sits down at a terminal that has a helmet attached to the ceiling via some wires. With a single motion, he sticks it on his head, and I quickly realize it's a virtual reality goggle set of some kind, except much bigger and bulkier than I would imagine.

A loud *beep* sounds off behind me and I turn to look. The entire wall has become a viewscreen, and several images appear and disappear, along with video and other things. Freddy pipes up. "You guys gonna buy anything, or what?"

Ben frowns at me and shrugs. "I'll buy a banana."

Freddy sighs. "Is that all? Standard price is a thousand for a bunch, four hundred credits for a single."

"I'll take a single." Ben and I stare at Freddy's back, and a moment later a whirring sound fills the room, and a banana pops out of a chute in the wall to the right of him, landing in a clean white basket.

"Eight hundred credits."

Ben bites his tongue but glares at me. *You're paying me back when we return*, his eyes seem to say.

A moment later, Ben presses more buttons on his datapad and sends the credits to Freddy, who barely acknowledges the transaction.

"Thanks, yadda yadda if you're not buying anything else, go ahead and leave." While still wearing the helmet that covers his face and eyes, he turns to look at us. "And don't try to steal anything either. I have multiple auto-turrets in the walls. You won't escape alive."

"Sure, we understand. Thank you for your time." Ben takes the banana and smiles lopsidedly at me. *Ohhh banana!*

"Total waste of time." Freddy grumbles to himself, so Ben and I take it as our cue to leave. We push past the door outside, and the girl from before leads us to the hotel entrance once again.

Blaarjiim stirs in my mind. *How curious. That boy was neither human nor demon... but a half-breed. I could sense the energy inside of him, as well as plenty of anger and bottled up emotions.*

I decide not to answer him while walking with a stranger and Ben, but merely nod and wonder to myself.

Once we're outside, Ben finishes off his banana and sighs contentedly. "Damn, I haven't tasted fruit in centuries. That was incredible."

He tosses the peel forward, and it lands on the concrete-like surface. Immediately, before our very eyes, the fruit shrivels up and hisses, as if someone were pouring boiling water into a bucket of ice cubes. Moments later, it vanishes and crumbles into dust.

"Wow. So that's how it works, huh?"

My question makes Ben smile. "Yeah, pretty cool, huh? Be glad I was there to stop you from touching it."

"Believe me, I am."

Part 416b: Written In Blood

I move the file across each nail slowly, deliberately, each pass a work of art, every movement done with purpose. I am a beautiful, divine being, and performing even the most menial task must be done with dignity and grace. When it comes to my personal hygiene, no expense must be spared, no amount of time considered too great for me to ensure I am always looking my best.

Yama, the short little Second Emperor, an ugly black mass of greed and avarice, walks beside me as we round the last corner to the gate that leads to the entrance of his domain. He has long since grown used to my 'fussy' mannerisms, my carefully constructed sentences, and my lust for perfection in all its forms, so he doesn't object as I file away.

Just as Grylls teleports the guests to our side, I stick the file into my inner suit pocket and bow gracefully. "Esteemed human guests, I welcome you to the Hidden Demon Capitol, Second Emperor Yama's domain. My name is Beelzebub, the Third Emperor of Hell."

The two humans shift nervously in front of us, obviously a little off-put by my stunning beauty, as well as Yama's frightening appearance. One of them I recognize, Jacob Lirik, a scientist at the Rygar nature preserve. He's a pudgy, overweight slob, one who slouches as he walks and mumbles when he talks but is also quite intelligent. Even for a human, I find him repulsive to look at, given his cleft chin and droopy eyelids make him seem like a homeless vagrant.

Unbelievably, despite his hideous appearance, he leads the entire Species Development Division on Rygar and is directly responsible for maintaining genetic disparities and similarities between the different types of animals... whatever that means. I only know this because when I asked him what his job was on the first occasion that I met him, he launched into a ten-minute tirade about how important he was and I nearly killed him for it.

Jacob wipes at his nose and beckons to his companion, who is trying his damndest to not quake in his boots at the atmosphere the two demons before him give off. "This is a friend of mine, David Jones. He's a Head Supervisor for the Botany and Biology Facility in the southern hemisphere. After I told him about this place, he couldn't wait to come."

Indeed, despite his shaking, there's an intangible excitement in David's eyes. He's as ugly as his senior, with a droopy turkey chin, legs as thick as a small tree, and arms that must wave back at him whenever he greets people. A thin layer of hair coats his face and neck, and faint flecks of drool are visible just underneath his lower lip.

Humans are repugnant creatures.

"G-good to meet you, mister demon lord sirs!" David thrusts his hand forward, presumably to shake our hands, but neither Yama nor I make any effort to return the gesture.

Jacob quickly shoves David and scowls at him. "They're *emperors*, not *lords*. They're royalty, so they don't shake hands with common folk like us."

Royalty. Mmm, I love the sound of that. I relax my posture slightly as the two humans trip over each other trying to praise us. Naturally, Yama and I are emperors, so it's only normal these men should treat us as their superiors. Without exerting any energy I could kill both of them in a single second, and they'd never realize I'd done it.

Yama finally speaks. "David Jones, is it? I'm delighted to see you here. As your friend may have told you, my domain is *private*, only available to *particular* humans, ones in positions of *authority*. Of course, in order to browse my wares, you must be willing to offer some quid-pro-quo."

David's eager smile slightly fades as he looks at Jacob. "I don't understand... w-what does he want? Perhaps... my blood?"

I secretly smile as Yama materializes a familiar parchment in midair, a *blood contract*. "Something to that extent. This contract guarantees by your own life's energy that you will never tell anyone else about my domain, and if you do, you must bring them here within two days or your life will be forfeit." Yama makes a big show of clearing his throat. "Oh yes, also, if I deem the person you bring to be of little value, your life will be forfeit immediately, as will theirs."

David's smile vanishes completely as he turns to look back at Jacob. "You knew about this? Are you also under the blood contract?"

Jacob's expression is tight. "I am. Unofficially, Yama will give extra benefits to those who regularly introduce him to prominent humans. I took a measured risk. I know you've been lonely, David. Since Yama has acknowledged your value to humanity, that means..." He turns to look at the Second Emperor and nods. "...that my offer is accepted?"

"Only if this one signs the contract." Yama thrusts the paper forward, along with a metal fountain pen. "It is as your friend explained, Mister Jones. You either sign, or both of you die now. It isn't much of a choice at this point, but rest assured, you are part of a secret society. I offer my protection to you while inside my domain, and no harm will come upon you as long as I draw breath. Additionally, women will be at your disposal, as will my food stores."

"You have food here as well?" David's eyes light up immediately, and he quickly but gently takes the parchment from Yama. "Where do I sign?"

Yama chuckles audibly, and even I can't help but laugh, myself. Humans are still simple creatures, in the end. *They're easy to manipulate.*

"Simply press the pen into your finger, allow the blood to coat its tip then place your name here." Yama's smoke trickles from his body to form a long finger, then points at the spot on the parchment.

A few moments later, the human has finished, the paper glows with energy, and Yama quickly takes it back, rolls it up, and sends it to his shadow realm to store it for safekeeping. "Welcome to the society of demons, David Locke Jones."

I stroke my chin hair and turn to Jacob. "You've brought us a new convert. As per our rules, you will be granted extra privileges. You may now enjoy the company of two slaves during your stay here, and their quality will go up as well."

Jacob wheezes and shifts his stance. "Ah, that's good... very good. I really only care for one of the girls here, but I guess I can find another. The more, the merrier, right?"

"Yes. I suppose so." I resist the urge to roll my eyes. "Do you have a preference on this outing, or would you rather have us line them up for you, as we did on your first arrival?"

He starts to shake his head, but quickly thinks better of it. "Normally I'd just want to see Melia, but since David isn't used to the whole process, and since I can have a second now, you might as well."

Yama twitches slightly, and a pained look crosses over his face. I quickly find out why when he explains. "I apologize, Mister Lirik. Melia is no longer among the living. I forgot your attachment to that one."

The change in Jacob's attitude is dramatic. It's as if an arrow were bursting through his chest. "What? She's dead?! But... but how? You said nobody could kill the slaves! You said you'd protect them!" He takes a step forward, and for a second a remarkable rage passes over his face, but neither Yama nor myself are intimidated.

"No. I said that if you were to ever kill a slave here, you would pay the price for your actions. This rule applies to all humans who enter a contract with my domain. Believe me, the human who killed her paid the ultimate price."

Jacob's anger quickly fades, and tears well up instead. He bows his head to avert his gaze and wipes furiously at his eyes. "Shit. Goddammit! I liked Melia! She was nice; she always took care of me! This... this isn't fair... she didn't deserve to die..."

Every human that comes to these lands comes for their own reasons, but men like Jacob are a real rarity. They treat the girls with affection and grow rather attached to the slaves... perhaps

too attached. Indeed, I remember the times he brought Melia gifts, such as a pillow and blankets to make her bed more comfortable. We confiscated them, of course, once he had left. There's no point allowing a slave to get any ideas about her sense of superiority compared to the others.

Still, this disgusting reject of society held a real affection for her. For a moment, I almost feel sorry for Jacob. That moment disappears as quickly as it came.

"If you would prefer, you can go home and grieve for her death. We will not blame you." I drawl out a generic offering of condolences, and he finishes weeping like a man-child and rubs his shirt on his eyes.

"No, I'm fine. Sorry for ending up like this. Let's go on, David. I need the company of a woman now more than ever."

David pats his colleague on the back, and I use magic to summon a familiar demoness to my side. An old hag appears, looking none too pleased that I used my teleportation on her. "What's the meaning of this? You little shithead! I was busy when you just yanked me outta the-"

"Shut it, Hellga. We've taken the tongues of all the human girls, and I wouldn't test my patience if I were you. I have infinitely less of it for an old bat like you." I snap at her viciously, and she immediately shuts up and waits for my orders. "Line up the serfs. We have a new distinguished visitor, and one of our returning friends would like to see what others we have available."

She nods with annoyance, the rage in her eyes evident, but she dares not question my orders. She might claim to be born of royal blood, but her power is a fraction of even an average demon's. Might makes right among our people, and she lacks the ability to fight back. Such is the natural order of things here.

Before she can lead the humans away, Yama pauses their departure with a single upright palm. "David, due to the incident that resulted in Melia's death, we lack several slaves. Be sure and let us know if you can get hold of any new ones to replace them."

The human nods glumly, and soon he and his friend leave, following closely behind Hellga. Yama sighs. "Jason Hiro... that human has caused so many problems for me."

Yama and I turn and walk down the hallways, meandering back and forth as we head to the front rooms, where the dining hall and Yama's storage rooms are located.

"Look at the bright side though, Second Emperor, and see what you've traded. Danis was a psychopathic torturer, a human that would be hard pressed to find like-minded company among the worst of his kind... or *ours*. He was an Admiral, too, while Jason Hiro is the leader of

all of humanity, and most especially their centralized forces. When you consider what we've gained compared to what we've lost, it's a net positive."

Yama doesn't seem so certain. The smoke boils and streams off his body, falls onto the floor, and hisses when it meets the cold black tiles. "Jason is an enigma. He protected one slave girl that he liked, and killed another without remorse. His actions are full of contradictions. He's unsure of what he wants to do. He's confused, lost. Yet, compared with the weakling that preceded him, this new Jason is a threat unlike any before him." Yama reaches up to tap his barely visible lip thoughtfully. "He might interfere with our long-term plans if he switches allegiances. I'm not certain I could kill him without bringing down all of humanity on us."

I reach into my coat and pull out a bottle of cologne, then dab a tiny bit on my neck before slipping the bottle back where it came from. "He's a disrespectful, arrogant little shit, but he's still more in our hands than the previous Jason was."

We stop in front of the door that leads to Yama's storage, and he releases the seal with a wave of his hand. "Is he? The previous Jason witnessed my power and realized that angering demons any more would result in a suicide attack that would threaten the balance of power in the galaxy. He was doing an excellent job keeping his troops at bay for the foreseeable future."

Yama's words send a chill down my spine as we enter the room where he stores his prized possessions. "That attack you speak of... no demon was able to witness it, yet what little we've heard of it from humankind indicates... well, with the power you put on display, surely you are a worthy candidate for First Emperor."

The short black demon's face contorts into a dark smile as he turns to look at me. "I allow Bael to hold that position for the safety of all demons. The humans have seen my power, but they have yet to see Bael's. If they know what I am capable of, and they suppose that Bael is a higher rank than me, then it stands to suggest in their minds that he is even more daunting of a foe than I."

"Clever. But Bael isn't stronger than you. In fact, I think he might be weaker than *me*." I press a finger to my chest to emphasize my point. "More importantly, I find it difficult to believe that you had the power to kill billions of humans all at once. How could you possibly pull that off?"

Yama turns away from me and wanders over to his favorite crystal, the one holding the body of the human female he loves to look at most. I don't understand his fascination with her. "My power is that of darkness, and the more humans I kill, the more powerful it becomes. Had the Supreme Commander not halted my advance with his Wordsmithing, I might have extinguished humanity in a single night."

I raise my eyebrows in interest. "I see. So you killed humans, which drained your power, but the more you exterminated, the more power you gained. A chain reaction."

"The Sirius system suffered a huge blow to their military morale as a result of that night. I am pleased with how it turned out."

Yama lowers his head and whispers under his breath. "And, if it weren't for the help of *that one*... I don't know if..."

"Huh? Who are you talking about?"

I interrupt his thoughts, and he shakes his head at me. "A human wrote a book once, in the time before time. In it, he stated the following: *To deceive your foes, you must first deceive your allies.* " Yama turns back to look at me. "*Appear weak when you are strong, and strong when you are weak.* In time, Beelzebub, you will understand the method to my madness."

"Are you planning something?"

The Shadow looks at a different crystal, one holding the body of the previous Supreme Commander. "Always."

* * *

I miss vacations. There was a time in my life when I wasn't a workaholic. I used to be able to enjoy the small things. Going to the beach, riding a Ferris Wheel, blasting through hyperspace for fun. Shoot, I even used to treat the people in my extended family differently, as if they were human beings, and not just moochers out to get in good graces with the Supreme Commander.

I don't know when it all changed... but once it did, that was the moment my life took a turn for the worse, and slowly deteriorated more and more over time. There was a time in my life when I was filled with anger and resentment, always looking for a fight. I crushed the demons and used their bodies to pave a path for humanity. At some point, the anger began to subside, and before I knew it, a million years had passed.

Marie was always there at my side, whispering to me. Was she a temptress? She spoke honeyed words to calm me down, time after time, and eventually a small ceding of control would pave the path to another, and then another... soon, I ended up sitting in an office all day, pressing buttons and grumbling my life away. The only respite I found was with my beautiful wife and the respect of my subordinates. But what did it matter in the end?

My life has become meaningless. I have a power that allows me to control the underlying principles of the universe, and I barely even use it. I'm not a spiritual man, but if God does exist, would he not be angered by my squandering of his gift? *Does God exist? Am I... God?*

I can't be God. God does not need to speak a word to make His will become reality. At best, I am a pale imitation, a muddled reflection in a broken mirror. Nobody will write a holy book about my life, nor will they bow down before me and praise my eternal power. Should they? All I've given humanity is a mediocre existence, a grim lifetime of strife. Food made from feces, work derived from meaningless button-pressing, and unfounded fears about an enemy that will never become a threat.

* * *

My consciousness feels so distant lately. I feel like I'm sleeping, yet I'm groggy, as if my body is waking up, but fails halfway through. What led to this? Why can't I just stay asleep or wake up? Haven't I worked hard enough? Can't I ever take a day off?

Footsteps. I hear the sound of someone walking toward me. From where?

"Funny. We clashed for millions of years, but in the end, it was not me who defeated you, but yourself."

Who's speaking? His voice sounds so far away. It's as if I'm underwater, and I can only hear his words through the liquid around me.

"I knew this would happen eventually, see. Beelzebub and the others can't understand. It's all part of the plan. You shouldn't blame yourself."

Blame myself? Who's speaking? What's he talking about?

"I'm glad though. You worked hard, all those eons. Nobody ever appreciated you, but now you may sleep. Sleep as much as you desire. You've earned it."

I think I recognize the voice. Is it Yama? How can I hear him?

The footsteps are audible again, but this time they walk away from me. Yama speaks again. "Amelia... always a pleasure to gaze upon you. Someday, my vindication will be upon us. When we crush the humans from within, I will release you. Perhaps then, you will finally be able to accept me."

The sound of footsteps again, first walking toward me, then walking away. Is Yama... pacing? His voice sounds uncertain as if he doesn't know what he's doing.

"Will you accept me, though? Why would you? I've locked you up like an animal. Am I cursed, never to feel your touch? Must we always keep this barrier between us? Perhaps it's for the best. If I could touch you, I don't know what I would do. I doubt my self-control... when it comes to our bond. You saved me, after all, but my feelings are more than that of gratefulness and respect. They're deep as the oceans on your home planet."

He continues pacing. "It is coming, though. The storm that will rend human society asunder. I never wanted war, you know. Satan was the one who wanted humans to die. I held no such moral qualms. He was a psychopath who could never let go of a grudge. You believe me, don't you? I wanted peace. It was he who instigated the war, and Jason Hiro who tried to purge us from existence. I am merely acting in self-preservation."

Yama's voice trails off, and he stops walking. "I wish you could answer me, but you can't. You're trapped in an infinite sleep. I put you there. I... I am... a monster. You could never love me as I do you."

There is silence for several long moments, followed by a choking sound, something I can only assume is... *sobbing*? Is he crying?

I hear the sound of his feet again, this time walking away from me. Just before he walks out of range entirely, Yama pauses. "I'll see you again, tomorrow, same time. Farewell, my love."

A slamming sound fills my ears. He has left, but where has he gone? And who is this Amelia he is talking to?

I'm getting tired again... perhaps I should... sleep.

I deserve the rest.

Part 417b: The Uprising

"Mister Feldmann can be a bit eccentric." Amy mutters the cautious warning as we approach the door to a rooftop elevator. Amy landed her ship on the landing pad several dozen feet behind us, and now this small building, back on Earth, is the place that will take me to whoever calls the shots. 'Mister Feldmann' is a man Amy looks up to, though she hasn't told me much about him.

"Eccentric? What is that?"

The door opens, and we step inside the small enclosed space, then Amy presses a button labeled '49'. "It means he can act a little strange, odd at times, perhaps even erratic. He has quirks that might surprise you, but you'll grow used to them. He's a very level headed guy, and dependable too, but first impressions aren't his strong suit."

Amy pulls on her long, curly blonde hair and spreads it out, fanning it all over. The new look makes her look much younger, and prettier too. "He's a real gentleman, and has a penchant for getting protective of cute girls. Make sure you use that to your advantage."

I follow her lead and fan my hair out, smiling as I feel how clean it is. I don't know why, but for some reason, I slept the entire trip to this place and didn't wake up until we reached Earth. Amy told me she gave me a 'said-uh-tiff', but I've never heard of those before. Whatever it was, it made me feel very sleepy. Once I woke up and showered again, I felt like a whole different person. I still do!

I watch the numbers light up on the door panel. 55, 54, 53, 52...

"It's an older building. Steven has his own suite in the upper districts, but this is a skyscraper built eons ago. It exists outside the monitoring zone because anyone living here is assumed to be not worth listening in on. At least, that's the official reason." Amy starts explaining things without me asking her to do so, but I keep quiet and listen, all the same. "The purpose of our organization is to quietly oppose the government where possible. Thankfully, people are starting to wake up and realize we were right all along."

"You oppose the government? That sounds dangerous."

The door dings and opens, and we step out into a brightly lit, pale white lobby. The walls are covered in noticeable water-spots here and there, and the sensation of rumbling from deep in the building below makes my feet tremble as we exit the elevator.

"Oh sure, there are dangers. The benefit of a society with hundreds of trillions of citizens is that no matter how powerful the government might be, unless they have an all-powerful AI that can be everywhere all at once, they can't possibly keep up with all people at all times. Anyway, our society has many punishments, especially for rebels who plot against their government, but the death penalty is not among them. *Officially.* "

Amy shivers slightly before looking at me with a fear in her eyes, something I haven't seen before. "You know... murder is, ah, unheard of. You've already killed a hundred people, *fellow humans*. No matter how much Mister Feldmann and I hated Danis, killing him left a sour taste in our mouths, but what you did at that prison facility was-

"I did what I had to. Master would be proud." I glare at her, though mostly out of anger that she'd question my motives. "They wanted to lock me up and torture me again. They deserved to die."

"I know, Lora. I understand that you were angry, but I thought you were just going to distract them. If I had known you were going to kill those men and the Warden, I would never have-

I stop walking and grab her by the shoulder. "So you've never killed anyone, then? Are your hands bloodless?"

She pulls away from my grasp. "I've never done such a thing, of course not!"

"Not humans, but what about demons?"

My question takes her aback. She rubs her arm and glances away. "Well, I mean, I've killed a few demons, sure. But demons aren't humans! There's a difference!" A fiery indignation lights up in her eyes. "You can't compare us to them!"

"I can! I will!" I hold up my fingers and start counting them off. "Demons are intelligent, they walk on two legs and have two arms, they look like humans aside from their red skin, they have hopes, dreams, and desires... just how many have you killed?"

Amy can't meet my gaze. "I don't know. I, well, I lost count."

There's a short silence as I glare at her and she won't look at me, but I finally pull away and start walking ahead again. "You've *lost count*? I will never forget the faces of those I killed. The only difference between you and me is that while we're both killers, I only kill to survive."

I can hear Amy's footsteps as she falls into line behind me. "I killed demons to protect humanity. They're monsters. They eat humans. They're just... not the same."

She's not wrong there. How many slaves did I watch the demons devour? Their screams echo in my nightmares sometimes. "Danis was more of a devil than most demons I met. So was the

Warden. In a way, you and I aren't very different. You killed demons, but I killed monsters, ones that wore human skin, but weren't really human."

Before long, the sounds of people walking around sound off in the distance, and soon we arrive in a large room, with chairs and furniture just like the ones I saw in Marie's home. Men and women are lounging around, eating food bars and chatting about this and that. An ornate rounded metal light-holder hangs from the ceiling, and it has over a hundred small sparkling points of light. Despite being the only source of illumination for the room, when I look at it, it reminds me of the 'star' that Master told me about on Earth.

Amy catches me looking at it. "That's a 'chandelier'. It's ancient, but Feldmann thought it would light up the dining hall and bring a cozy atmosphere for everyone to relax in."

I nod. "Who are all these people?"

"They're part of the resistance. Some joined after the Goldesh Uprising went south and the government showed its true colors. Most were on board even before them, but few are as powerful or influential as Steven Feldmann."

We continue walking past people, and Amy pauses to greet a few of them, even going so far as to introduce me, but all their faces and names tend to blend together in my mind.

Finally, Amy stops in front of a door on the opposite side of the room from where we started. She inhales slowly, then sighs. "As I thought. Peggy told me Steven is playing holo-games again. The man is an addict. We'll go in, but just... watch out for an outfield curveball."

"A what?"

She doesn't explain, but instead opens the door. We enter the room, and immediately everything feels weird. The hard-wood floors from outside suddenly become soft and green, like the ground-sticks from outside the prison facility. There's a sound, hundreds of feet away, of a metallic *whack* hitting something with tremendous force. Every few seconds, I hear the sound again, and again... Amy seems familiar with it, so I follow her. When we walk over a small hill, I spot a man, presumably Feldmann, standing by himself, holding a long metal rod in his hands. He's wearing shorts without a shirt, and a man is standing opposite him throwing a round white object at Feldmann. Each time he throws it, Feldmann swings the metal rod out and hits the white thing away. We're standing behind Feldmann, so he doesn't appear to see us.

"Is he training for battle?" I ask the question, and Amy chuckles in response.

"He's practicing his batting. He loves baseball, you see. He won't shut up about it, if you let him start at all."

"What is baseball?"

Amy shrugs. "It's an ancient sport, invented by primitive humans before the dawn of immortality. You hit the ball and get points or something. Seems silly to me."

Points? Why would he want to get points? Perhaps they're edible.

We continue watching him swing the rod and hit the balls, and once he pauses to wipe at his forehead, Amy decides that's the moment to get his attention. "Mister Feldmann! I'm back."

He quickly turns around and raises an eyebrow when he spots us. "Amy! Glad to see you again!" He drops the rod on the ground, makes a motion with his hands, and the other man vanishes, as if by magic. "And this other girl...?"

As he trots up to us, Amy gestures at me. "This is Lora... something. I don't know her last name. She's the one you wanted to see."

"Do I need to have a last name?"

My innocent question makes Feldmann chuckle. "Hehe, no, not really. In any case... you worked for my father, then?"

I stare at him silently and shrug. Amy raises an eyebrow. "You did work for the Supreme Commander, correct? Jason Hiro. You wouldn't stop mumbling his name in your sleep."

I quickly realize what they're saying. "Oh! Master is your father? I'm sorry! He never told me he had a son!"

Steven glances at Amy, then back to me. "I'm sorry... *master*? What do you mean by that?" He clears his throat and looks back to Amy. "Were they in some sort of *relationship*? It sounds questionable..."

"He saved me from the demons. They were holding me as a slave, so he took me from them..." I trail off as both of them seem unnerved by my words.

Steven wipes some sweat from his chest. "Oh, so it's like that. I understand. I never took Father to be a do-gooder, but he's been full of surprises lately." He jerks his thumb back at where he was playing with the rod from earlier. "Why don't you join me? It's no fun just standing around; I like to get some exercise in when I'm not at the office."

"Okay. Exercise is good! It makes you stronger!" I follow after him, but glance back and notice Amy looks slightly annoyed. "What's wrong?"

She shakes her head. "I'll just sit and watch. I'm not interested in playing games right now."

Amy tags along and sits on the green sticks, while Steven waves his hands in the air and makes a small rectangular steel cage appear, filled to the brim with those white balls from

earlier. "Just grab one of those baseballs and throw them to my side. I'll hit it, then you throw another when I'm ready, and we'll keep repeating it over and over."

I nod slowly and stand beside the cage. "Is this exercise?"

"Certainly! It's a full upper body workout for me, and it can even help you develop some arm strength too." He pauses to pick the rod up from the ground. "Also, the best thing about sports... you can easily judge a person's character by how they play the game."

Amy perks up behind him. "Is that what this is about?"

"Perhaps." He takes a ready stance and holds the metal rod up. "Just pitch the ball to my side. Ever thrown a baseball before?"

I grab one and shrug. "I've thrown rocks before. I'll try to be gentle."

"No, that's fine. Throw as hard as you can. I hit 100mph fastballs all the time. I train with holographic recreations of all the greatest pitchers, after all."

Amy nods along, but there's suddenly a look of alarm in her eyes. She quickly stands up and runs to the side, getting away from standing behind him. "Uh, Steven, you should watch out! She's way stronger than she looks!"

"Uh huh." He watches my hand carefully, as I wind up to throw the ball just like I saw that man from earlier do. The moment the ball leaves my hand, a massive explosion sounds off behind Steven, and the ground shakes furiously as the ball pounds into the field with the fury of a cannonball.

Steven's eyes open a little wider as he turns to look at the terrain behind him. Where there was once green sticks, the world looks weird and deformed. Sparks fly out in all directions, and he turns back to me and gawks. "Y-you just destroyed a part of the holo-room! Holographic balls aren't supposed to cause damage like that!"

"I warned you." Amy shakes her head chidingly. "Don't try it again, Steven. She might kill you, even if by accident."

Steven drops the rod from his hands and quickly wipes sweat from his bare chest. "Yeah... no kidding. What did the demons do to make you so powerful?"

Amy and Steven both walk over to me, and I shake my head. "Master trained me constantly."

"Yeah, no kidding. He must have juiced you up real good. Let's call it a day." Steven surprises me by reaching over suddenly and squeezing my arm. "You should be made of solid muscle, but this is the most ladylike arm I've ever squeezed. How did he do it, I wonder?"

We walk toward the exit door, and I tap my lip thoughtfully. "I'm not sure. Master just said a word, and I was stronger!"

Amy fills in for me. "She was born and raised in the Labyrinth, from what I gather, Steven. She wouldn't know how nano-augmentation works. I can't fathom what your father was thinking when he altered her genetics, though."

Steven nods. "Yeah. He's been acting strange, lately. Marie's taking an abrupt vacation, too. Suspicious timing, if you ask me."

Just as we near the door, Amy scowls at Steven. "Aren't you going to put on a shirt before we go out?"

"Pff. Who needs 'em?"

* * *

A few minutes later, the three of us sit at a long 'bar,' as Steven calls it, and I admire the wooden stool before me. It's made with excellent craftsmanship, and the seat has a winged creature resembling the lizard-men I'd seen a few times in the Labyrinth, but with a mouthful of razor-sharp teeth. It's hard to tell, but it seems the monster is breathing fire. Whatever it is, the beast is etched into the chair with perfectly detailed line-work. Only Yama had anything similar in the labyrinth, and he kept all artistry of such quality under lock and key in his storage room.

I quickly sit down, and Feldmann leans forward to look past Amy, who's sitting between us. "We haven't had time for a proper introduction yet, have we? I'm Steven Feldmann, and my father is your former boss. My job on the council is mostly a ceremonial role, where I'm considered a military advisor, but I can leverage it to my political advantage as needed."

I nod slowly, unsure of what anything he said means. A large man with a grizzled beard and a shirt ripped in various places on the arms walks up from behind the counter and grunts. "Mister Feldmann, what'll it be?"

"I'll take a gin. The ladies will have..." He trails off, and Amy finishes for him.

"Give me a light craft beer, if you please." She turns to me. "Do you drink as well, Lora?"

I'm a little confused by what she means. "Won't you die if you don't drink?"

"Some days, I feel like it." Steven grumbles under his breath, but Amy lightly punches him in the arm and turns back to me.

"Alcohol, dear. Have you ever had alcohol before?" I shake my head, and immediately she turns back to the bartender. "She's a young thing, Brian. Start her off with something light and flavorful. Low alcohol content."

He grumbles to himself and mutters something inaudible, then reaches under the counter to pull up a cup and a red-colored bottle. "This'll do. Made this myself. Cherry Cider." He pours the red juice inside and shoves it in front of me, then grabs the drinks for Amy and Steven. "Want this on your tab?"

Steven nods. "That'll be fine."

I stare at the red liquid for a few moments as a fragrant aroma rises into my nose. It smells good, though I can't place the scent at all. I take a sip of it, and the taste is so incredible that a moment later I down the rest of the glass in one gulp. A pleasant feeling washes through my body, something relaxing that makes me want to kick back and 'take it easy,' as Master would sometimes say.

Brian raises an eyebrow. "Want more, little girl?"

"Mhm."

He shrugs and pours another glassful, so I drink it in one gulp again, then eyeball the glass curiously. The glass seems to be moving. Ah, everything is.

"That will be enough for her. She doesn't look like she can handle her liquor." Amy pats me on the back. "You shouldn't have drunk it so fast."

Steven gets up and walks around to my other side, bringing his glass with him. He sits on the stool beside me. "So, listen, I've had a look at what few records the prison system had for you. Can you answer a few questions for me?"

I yawn loudly and lay my head on my hand, propping myself up on the counter. "Uh huh."

"You're from Goldesh, right? That's what the scanning report said when my father brought you out of the Labyrinth. Is that correct?" He takes a sip of the beverage in his hands but keeps his eyes locked on me.

My eyes feel a little droopy. "I don't know..."

"Hmm." He looks past me at Amy. "She was born and raised in the Labyrinth, right? She might not even know what Goldesh is." He finishes his drink and sets it down. "Listen... Lora. The man you killed, Danis. He was an evil man. Amy and I knew it for hundreds of years. We aren't mad that you killed him, per se, but we need to find out more details. Why did you kill him, if you didn't know what happened on Goldesh?"

I was feeling drowsy before, but now all the memories come racing back. I suddenly feel uncomfortable sitting next to Steven and pull away from him slightly. "He... Danis... he beat me. He hurt my friends too. He did wicked things. Master saved me."

As if I flipped a switch, Steven leans a little away from me, having noticed my discomfort. "I'm sorry to hear that. If it's possible, could you go into more detail?"

I quickly shake my head and look away. "No, I don't want to. I really don't want to..."

Amy puts her hand on mine. "That's fine; we won't pressure you. Rather than ask for answers, *Steven*, since she doesn't know the importance of Goldesh, I think it's time we explained what happened."

Steven clears his throat. "Sorry. I get a little distracted whenever his name comes up. Everyone respected him, all those millennia, but I know the truth. *We* do, don't we, Amy?"

Amy turns back to glance at the room full of people milling about behind us. "I hope so. Should I tell her?"

"You were there too. Go ahead."

Amy lifts my chin up and makes me meet her eyes. "This is very important. It all started several hundred years ago."

* * *

I remember it as clearly as if it happened yesterday.

I was a mid-ranking member of the Golden Commandos at that point, and my squad was busy hunting down demons, as they always did. An order came down from top command, via the Supreme Commander himself. He wanted all of the Golden Commandos to examine ongoing unrest in the Goldesh system all by ourselves. Instead, since we were currently busy, Corporal Williams sent me to investigate. We couldn't possibly spare any other troops since the demons were attempting a comeback.

I blasted off and arrived a day later at Goldesh IV, a mining colony on one of the planet's moons. It was an ugly black rock, a blob of mass floating in space that certainly didn't care about the health of its human inhabitants. I had never been to the Goldesh system before, and certainly never a mining facility, not in my whole life. I didn't know what I was in for until I got there.

Immediately, I was struck by the darkness. The black ground seemed to absorb light from all around, so I always felt as if a demon could jump out of the shadows and attack me. When I arrived, I quickly spotted the problem. There was a large group of people protesting their working conditions. It turned out that the undesirables of society, specifically people who couldn't be rehabilitated for behavioral problems, yet who had committed no crimes, they were being sent to this mining facility, with no hope of ever leaving.

I'm not a fan of ration bars, and after spending a few days among the Goldeshians, I came to realize just how bad the bars could get. All food was ninety-five percent reconditioned, or worse. The miners were forced to work long hours, often sixteen a day, and conditions inside the mines were atrocious.

Angered by the protestors holding up supply lines, the facility guards were deployed to make sure all protestor names were noted and prevented from receiving any rations. They were corralled and starved and eventually driven into a corner. With no food or water, they became desperate for a change, and thus the first violent scuffle broke out at the mining facility.

During the chaos, a guard fired a shot that killed one of the protestors. This ended the fighting in an instant, but even though his fellow guardsmen were horrified by what he'd done, it was too late. Word spread about his actions, and the entire workforce went on strike. Armed with nothing but their fists and rocks mined from deep underground, the violence escalated rapidly, and five guards were killed that same day in retaliation for the death of the miner.

I didn't know what to do. From my perspective, the facility was a human rights violation, betraying everything I'd spent my life fighting for. The demons were supposed to be the bad guys, but humans were enslaving each other! On the other hand, the miner retaliation was over the top. An eye for an eye just leaves both sides blind, or at least that was how I explained the situation to myself.

It was then that two new faces arrived. General Danis, and the Supreme Commander's son, his most trusted advisor, Steven Feldmann.

The two men weren't familiar to me at all, but I was a soldier. When Danis ordered me to don my commando hypersuit and put an end to the violence, at *any* cost, I did what I had to.

First, I searched for the leaders of the resistance and captured them. It turned out just three women and two men were the ones in charge. They were the first people ever to be forced to work at the facility, and they had been there for almost a million years. I captured and turned in all five of them, and to my horror, Danis did something I would never have imagined.

He ordered a public execution.

"Law and order is to be maintained! Any who wish to complain have no voice, and they have no rights! Remember the human creed: *For glory, we aspire. Perfection, we achieve. Waste, we prevent. Failure, we despise.* None of you have any glory, all of you are the wastes and failures of this society, and thus only by working here will you ever achieve anything! Revolt if you wish, but death will be your only answer!"

Danis's voice rang out over loudspeakers set up all around the camps, and I watched as women and children shook in terror, unsure of what would come next. I was thankful that

Danis didn't order me to carry out their executions by firing squad, but I could tell he wanted to give me the 'honor'.

When the soldiers raised their plasma rifles, one of the mining leaders, still chained to a pole, and unable to escape, smiled. "You think this is a loss?! I will die, and go to Heaven! I should have done this years ago!"

Danis smiled back. Somehow, it made me feel a million times worse than any anger would have. "We will see what the angels think of lowlifes like you."

The soldiers blasted them, and the miners died instantly. Danis came to me later and praised me for my efforts in quickly stopping the mining uprising. He told me I'd be promoted... but I didn't want it. It was as if I were being given blood credits. I had only earned the promotion by hurting my own kind.

I couldn't help myself. I went to a distant part of the work outpost and cried for hours. I felt so guilty! What was I even fighting for? Killing demons was one thing, but enslaving other humans?! Every piece of our law expressly forbids it! Who is to say these people were the dregs of society? What arbitrary metrics determined that they, and thus their children, didn't have the right to live free lives?

Unfortunately for me, or so I thought at the time, Steven Feldmann was passing by and he heard me crying. He walked over and startled me by putting his hand on my shoulder. I jumped in fright, but the sight of the Supreme Commander's third-born son, a man I only knew in passing thanks to historical archives, only served to enrage me. I couldn't take it anymore! I unloaded on Steven, and attacked everything about him and what he stood for. Danis was a leader of humanity, and so was the Supreme Commander, and everyone else who allowed the facility to exist.

But Steven just stood there nodding, accepting my pain and anger. Eventually, he pulled me in close and hugged me, and I finally realized I wasn't alone. He was crying as well, deep on the inside.

His whole life, Steven did whatever his father told him, and only in the few millennia before the Goldesh incident did he realize the empire of humanity wasn't as utopian as it always appeared. Only once he saw those men executed and heard my genuine rage did he realize that what he was fighting for was a sham.

But this... this was only the beginning. Steven and I made an oath, right then and there, that we would not allow these people to be taken advantage of. We had to found a new order, one that could, in time, oppose the government. Steven had never truly loved his father, nor felt an emotional connection with him. Growing up, his father was barely ever home, always running

around doing this and that. Steven had lived for tens of millions of years, but all he ever did was live in his father's shadow.

We decided the first thing to do would be to organize a new resistance movement... and this time, we were going to do it right.

* * *

Amy sighs. "Steven... have we ever wavered? Have we done the right thing?"

"I think so." He sloshes another half-full glass around slowly. "Lora, you were around my father for a while. What did you think of him?"

His question makes me rub my legs. Something about the way these two keep probing makes me feel uncomfortable. "He is a kind master. He doesn't hit me or hurt me as the demons did... and Danis." I stop myself from saying anything else, but Steven immediately presses the issue.

"Wait, Danis hit you? What the hell? How could that be? Didn't you say you lived in the Labyrinth?"

Amy shoots icy daggers out of her eyes, but I just rub my arms and lean away.

"Um, well, yes. I lived in Yama's domain. He had many slave girls, just like me. He still does... they're all down there. He, um, offers them to visitors. Human visitors, that is..."

I glance up guiltily at Steven, but he isn't looking at me anymore. Instead, he's staring blankly at the wall behind the counter.

"Holy... fucking shit. No way. I knew he was corrupt, but- collusion with the demons? What if my father's invol-" He stops and immediately turns to me. "Is he?! Is my father involved in all of this?!"

He grabs me by the arms and shakes me, but Amy jumps in and pulls him off. "Calm down! Use your brain, idiot! Your father saved her from the demons. Of course he isn't involved with them. Read between the lines, Steven!"

She quickly pulls me out of the chair, and only now do I realize everyone is watching us. "Come on, Lora, this is probably rough on you. Let's go to your room and get a little breathing space, alright?"

"Uh, sure. Th-thanks." I look back as we walk away and stare silently at Steven, now holding his glass, his hand trembling the whole time.

"Is Steven okay?"

Amy shakes her head. "No, sweetheart. He isn't... but it's not your fault."

We walk down several hallways and stair passages before stopping at a door. "This is my vacation room, where I stay if I ever get kicked out of my suite in the upper districts. You can live here for the immediate future." She presses her hand on a black pad sticking out of the wall, then gestures for me to do so. "I have to register your biometric data. Once you're registered, you can come and go as you please."

I follow her directions and place my hand on the pad. A light illuminates my hand, and I can't help but giggle. "It... it tickles!"

A few seconds later, she lifts my hand off, and the door opens, sliding to the side, into the wall. "This room is nothing special, but it has plenty of nutrition bars, and a bed, and even a viewscreen if you want to watch something to pass the time."

We walk inside, and I slowly sit down on a soft, comfy-looking chair. "Is there anything else to eat other than the nutrition bars?"

"No, sorry."

"Oh. That's a shame. Yama always had regular food, even though slaves weren't allowed to eat it. Why do humans not have any?"

Amy's eyes widen in surprise. " *Really?* Yama possessed human food? How did he acquire it?"

"I don't know."

"That's fine." She looks out the window to the world beyond.

I shuffle my feet slightly and glance over at her. "Can I talk to Master?"

"Huh?" She shakes her head and clears a fog from her brain. "You mean Jason Hiro? Not just yet. Listen, you don't know the full story about him. Before you go rushing back to his side, perhaps you should hear our side of the story. From my perspective, Jason is an evil man. Even his son hates him. After you hear what I have to say, you can leave then, okay?"

"Okay." I pull my legs up in the chair and rest my head on my knees. "What else happened on Goldesh? You said you started to lead a rebellion..."

Amy swallows painfully, and her gaze sweeps over the mostly-empty room. "Yeah. We put our plan into motion just a few months later..."

Part 418b: The Inquisition

"I met Steven Feldmann during a lunch-hall meeting. I walked in to get myself a nutrition bar, and to my surprise, the Supreme Commander's son was standing with a group of miners, listening respectfully to their complaints. I'll spare you the boring details, but after I walked over and talked to him, I could tell instantly he had the same misgivings that I did about Goldesh IV's political situation. The whole mining facility was wrong, just wrong. It was modern day slavery."

Amy leans back on the bed and uses her hands to prop herself up. I take the time to crawl onto the bed and lay back with my head on a pillow. Compared to the cramped bed-space on her ship, this bed is astoundingly comfortable. I haven't had a chance to sleep on something this comfortable since Marie allowed me in her room, and before then, never.

"Slavery, huh? That sure sounds awful." I keep my tone neutral and sigh inwardly. I don't know what mining was like on Goldesh IV, but the demons made slave girls dig holes in the walls on many occasions, and the punishment for slacking was always swift and brutal. The mining colony sounds like heaven compared to how I grew up.

"Oh... it *was* terrible. The miners were living in something not far from Hell itself. The surface of Goldesh IV was a scorching desert during the day and a frozen wasteland at night. The tents they were supposed to sleep in were poorly insulated, so most miners would go and huddle up in the mines where it was a more moderate temperature. A few people suffered health complications due to the poor medical treatment available at the facility and the toxins in the air, particularly deeper in the mines."

"That sounds... terrible." I don't know why, but I suddenly feel irritated hearing about 'Goldesh this' and 'Goldesh that'. "Can I ask, Amy, what Goldesh has to do with me?"

Her sad expression turns into one of confusion. "As I told you before, you have Goldeshian blood in your veins. What happened on Goldesh probably directly led to your life in the Labyrinth."

"If you tell me everything you know about Goldesh, will it bring my mother back?"

My question instantly strikes a nerve. Amy pauses, and a pained expression crosses over her face. "I... I didn't mean anything like that. Look, Lora, at some point, the events on Goldesh led to the life you're living now. I helped lead a silent revolution, with the intent of ferrying the miners to outer worlds where they wouldn't be found. At some point, Feldmann and I were

compromised, and after I was forced to leave and rejoin the Golden Commandos, Steven told me that things became grim."

"How grim?"

"Very much so. Danis started cracking down on protest activity in the name of the law, and then he started sending disruptive men and women to prisons, such as the one I rescued you from on Tarus II. The thing is..." Amy stops talking for a moment and sits up straight, only to brush away her soft, blonde hair as it falls in front of her eyes. "...I tried to keep Goldesh out of sight and out of mind. Everyone thought I quelled the insurrection, but in fact, I was practically its initial conspirator. Only once I met you and learned about your life story did I realize something... and it's been haunting me for several days now. I... I may have given Danis the opportunity to imprison the female Goldeshians."

I roll over on the bed and face away from Amy. "I already know that. I realized once you started telling me the story. Don't blame yourself. Danis was an evil man."

"This is bigger than Danis. This goes all the way to the top." Amy's voice has an edge of resolve to it now. "Jason Hiro, the one you call Master... he was probably involved as well."

My face scrunches in thought. "Master wouldn't do that. I know him better than you. He's not kind or compassionate, but he hates it when women are hurt. He nearly killed Danis himself, before I did."

"Oh?" Amy lifts her voice in surprise. "Really? I was under the impression that when you murdered Danis, it caught everyone by surprise."

"No, that was when I killed Danis the second time. I killed him in the Labyrinth first, but Master cloned him and sent him back out."

Silence. After a few moments I tilt my head back to look at Amy, and she's gawking at me in response. "What? You killed Danis twice? How is that possible?"

I shake my head and look away from her again to stare at the far wall, covered in paintings and other fancy objects I can't even identify. "While Master was training me in the Labyrinth, I came across Danis. He had... he had killed two of my closest friends. Master was going to kill Danis himself, but before he could do the deed, I killed Danis myself. It was the most painful thing I've ever done in my life."

"You poor thing. I don't mean to prod, but if you killed Danis once, how could you possibly kill him again?"

"Master cloned him. He wanted Danis to go back to humanity and continue living normally."

Amy is silent for a few moments. "A cloning mechanism. This explains so much. Perhaps... perhaps the Supreme Commander has been executing political dissidents, then replacing them with clones. But, the only problem is, I always thought Jason Hiro was on the same side politically as Danis Thornum. Everything pointed to it. Was I wrong? Did he want you to kill Danis the second time?"

"No. Master is definitely angry at me. He looked so disappointed when he saw what I had done. How can I face him now?"

"Okay." Amy rustles around on the bed behind me and lays down, pressing her back to mine. "This is a lot to take in. I heard nothing of Danis's angelic form being discovered in Heaven. Could he have been executed on arrival? Does this involve the angels too?"

She pauses. "No... this could go deeper. What if the angels and demons are conspiring together to kill all of humanity off? But if Jason Hiro is pro-demon, why did he take issue with Danis? I don't understand. I'm missing so many pieces to the puzzle."

I accidentally let out a loud yawn, and it interrupts Amy's train of thought. "Oh, are you tired already?"

"Sorry. I just feel so sleepy, ever since I drank that cherry cider."

"I'm a little exhausted myself. I flew that ship for a full day straight. Let's catch some shut-eye and talk about it later, alright?"

"Okay."

"Good night, Lora."

I fidget with my fingers slightly. "When we wake up, can I speak with Master?"

"Um... we'll see. I have to ask Steven if it's alright with him."

"Oh... okay. Thank you, Amy."

* * *

Ben presses a series of buttons on the holo-table in the center of my suite, while the dog, Milkduds, watches with a hint of boredom on her face. A series of graphs and charts appear and hover over the table.

He points at one graph in particular. "The black market takes probably 10% of all wasted food, at least as far as my informant estimates. Even if you shut down the black market and redistribute the food, it won't measurably impact the whole of humanity in the slightest, and certainly not for any positive gains."

"This isn't just about food, Ben, think about psychology. Allowing this black market to exist means we're giving people a way to disrespect the government. I should use my Wordsmithing to create new energy sources that can give humanity the energy it needs. With that energy, we can power replicators, and the necessity of the black market system would vanish overnight."

Ben groans audibly and shakes his head. "You absolutely cannot use Wordsmithing in that way. Nobody aside from a few select humans, and apparently the Demon Emperors, know that you are a Wordsmith. If the Supreme Commander of humanity were revealed to have magical powers, it would be madness. We'd have riots within the hour, generals would struggle to keep the military in control, and there would be accusations that we were conspiring with the demons."

Heh. That's a funny thought, considering I somewhat *am* conspiring with them. Ben probably knows that though, given he's seen my memories.

"Okay, but surely there's a way I can use my Wordsmithing to benefit humanity somehow. I don't see why Marie hasn't explored every possible option to improve life for mankind."

"You're wrong. She's tried many systems. This one, as dysfunctional as it might seem to an observer like you, has had the greatest success and stability. Remember Edgar?"

"The guy we played billiards with? Yeah, I remember. What about him?"

Ben waggles his finger at me. "When we left, Edgar was on the way to working his way back up the ladder again. By making life as miserable as possible for lower class citizens, and offering a system for the talented to climb their way up a ladder to a better lifestyle, they have direct incentive to work their tails to the bone."

I raise an eyebrow. "Life at the top doesn't seem that great though. The foods almost as shitty at the top as it is at the bottom. Whether a nutrition bar is 5% real food or 35%, it's still made of shit in the end."

"Sure, if you look at the system just from the perspective of food. It's not that bad though. The air is cleaner, the suites are nicer, and bigger to boot..."

"Not everyone can be an upper-class citizen though, Ben. It's literally impossible. Under Marie's system, there will always be a swath of the population living in total poverty. That's immoral."

Ben chuckles and pets the dog to his side. "Immoral? Listen to you, the guy who murdered a little girl in cold blood. You're one to talk."

"That's not an argument. What I did was wrong, yes, but that doesn't make Marie's society worth living in."

"I didn't say it was. Jason, Marie already tested out a society where humans could have anything they wanted. It was awful, and soon exploded into chaos. If you give people everything they want, they'll just want more."

"So you keep half the population in perpetual poverty, and dangle a carrot in front of them expecting them to work hard just to get a lick of it, only for them to find out they can never have it?"

To my surprise, it's not Ben, but Mishmash who speaks up. "It doesn't matter, does it, Jason? Marie is right. By keeping the weakest, slowest, dumbest members of society at the bottom, they'll never be able to gather themselves up and fight back. Who cares if they're mad at their poverty? They can't do anything to change the system. They're powerless."

I glare at the dog. "Shut up, mutt. The fuck does a demon hound know about socio-economics anyway?"

She rolls her eyes. "More than you, apparently."

"I'll throw you off that balcony again if you press me."

"I'd welcome it at this point." She curls up in a ball at Ben's feet and pretends to ignore me. I'm not fooled though, I know that animal is trouble.

Ben coughs into his fist. "Anyway, this is all superfluous. Even if you *could* create an energy system with Wordsmithing, and even if humanity just went along with you being a Wordsmith, it could cause jealousy and fear among the Volgrim. Above all other things, we can't let that happen."

"Why?"

Ben shrugs. "Dunno. All I'm certain of is that Marie never, ever wanted to go to war with them. Her fear was rather irrational, for a woman as calm as she was."

"Hmm."

* * *

TEMPORAL DATE 4815.23P: INTERVIEW LOG FOR SUBJECT MARIE 12F, REGARDING THE APPEARANCE OF UNKNOWN ENTITY, HENCEFORTH DUBBED 'JASON X'. INTERVIEW CLASSIFICATION LEVEL: ALPHA BRANCH ONLY.

Subject Marie 12F is seated at interview table. Her interviewer is Temporal Adjunct Marie 7A.

Marie 7A: I've started the recording. I'm going to try and keep this interview brief, so let's get right to it. Due to special circumstances surrounding your universe, the Council has been forced to declassify several confidential files just for this debriefing, so please keep your answers short and succinct.

Marie 12F: I understand.

Marie 7A: Good. As I'm sure you're aware, Maries from Source universes ordinarily are not privy to a variety of highly classified information, specifically regarding Wordsmithing, but also including the state of other time-streams. We have hesitantly decided to temporarily lift this information embargo, but only on a need-to-know basis.

Marie 12F: Am I allowed to ask questions?

Marie 7A: If you must, but don't expect any answers.

Marie 12F: (Subject shifts in her seat.) Um, very well.

Marie 7A: Your universe is a unique one. Of all the possible ways it might have turned out, yours is the only one that has no ongoing wars. It is a veritable bastion of peace, compared to other universes.

Marie 12F: Yes, I'm very proud of my work.

Marie 7A: You are? How could you be proud unless you know the state of other universes?

Marie 12F: Well, I mean, I have heard that other universes are usually embroiled in violence. I don't know much about them, though.

Marie 7A: (Adjunct makes a note on her datapad.) If you've heard information about the other universes, who told you? Was it an informant? A mole?

Marie 12F: Ah, no. In fact, I believe I learned bits and pieces from the call-center Maries. Sometimes things just slipped out. I couldn't tell you who said it though... it was a long time ago.

Marie 7A: They just... slipped out? I see. I'll have to call for a review of this later.

Marie 12F: Am I in trouble? Have I broken any rules?

Marie 7A: That's what we're here to find out. I will not be the Marie deciding on your status, in any case, so try to remain alert.

Marie 12F: (Subject taps her fingers slowly on the table in front of her.) I'll do my best.

Marie 7A: As per my instructions regarding newly declassified information, I must inform you of disturbing developments in the multiverse. But first, a question. What do you know with regards to the operation of the multiverse?

Marie 12F: (Subject pauses to tap her lips.) Well, I have, ah, *heard* that there are Source Universes, and Traveler universes. Both are created by Wordsmiths.

Marie 7A: Yes. Go on.

Marie 12F: Ninety-nine percent of universes are Traveler universes, but Source universes are extremely rare.

Marie 7A: Ah, that percentage was official at one point, but it's outdated now. It's actually 99.9996% of all universes that are Traveler created.

Marie 12F: I see. Sorry, but I don't follow the point you're making. This seems rather semantic...

Marie 7A: To you, it might appear that way. There has been a disturbing increase in the number of universes that are part of the multiverse. In the past, we would see a few new universes form every so often, so keeping track of the new variants wasn't too tedious. Every new universe generally held a Marie we could initiate contact with, and so we could use her to find out the state of affairs.

Marie 12F: And that changed?

Marie 7A: Very much so. More importantly, the universes being created have no Maries for us to contact. Several thousand years ago, over a million universes appeared in a single week's time. You were not told this, of course, because you are a Source Marie. There was a huge panic over what caused this rapid expansion, and while it didn't maintain the speed of expansion for long, since then the rate of expansion has increased tenfold over what it was before the incident.

Marie 12F: So instead of a few universes every now and then...

Marie 7A: One new universe develops every single day now, at the minimum. All of them lack Maries, and none of them have a visible Jason present anywhere.

Marie 12F: If I may ask, do you have a working theory over what's causing this?

Marie 7A: Of course. Believe it or not, the current theory is that all these new universes are obfuscation, that is, background noise just to distract us. It's reasonable to assume that a rogue Jason is running loose, creating new universes, and then leaving afterward. Somewhere within these universes, there may be a plot being hatched to destroy the Temporal Council.

Marie 12F: (Subject pauses for 14.5 seconds before responding.) I see why you're in a small panic over this, but I don't see what it has to do with me, or why I'm being questioned right now.

Marie 7A: That's understandable. We've been reviewing the memory files for Jason X, the new arrival in your universe, and we've found disturbing information. It calls into question the

very nature of your universe.

Marie 12F: (Subject stiffens in her seat and a look of alarm visibly passes over her face.) Are... are you saying I have something to do with this? I assure you, I've given you everything I have to offer! I followed the proper protocols!

Marie 7A: Calm down, this isn't about you. We have several key things noted in your personality file, notably one of them is a statement that you 'Keep Jason 12F on a leash like a loyal dog', is that correct?

Marie 12F: Well, yes, I may have made that statement at some point in the-

Marie 7A: You've also stated on many occasions that you have firm control over your Source universe. Is that also correct?

Marie 12F: I believe so... yes.

Marie 7A: Are you familiar with Wordsmithed clones?

Marie 12F: Huh? What's this change of topic about?

Marie 7A: I assure you, it is relevant. Have you become aware of the concept of a Wordsmith cloning himself or someone else?

Marie 12F: I've never seen it happen, but of course I have theories that it could work.

Marie 7A: So you unilaterally deny ever ordering Jason 12F to clone himself?

Marie 12F: Of course. Controlling one wordsmith is hard enough, and I wouldn't do something like that unless I had permission from the Temporal Council.

Marie 7A: And you've never taken steps to clone Jason 12F yourself, using any form of technology, or any biological augmentation?

Marie 12F: (Subject rubs her hands together and avoids eye contact with the Adjunct for a few moments.) No. Well, not Jason, anyway. As I said, I'd never do something so dangerous with a Wordsmith. However, for the, err, the wife that I introduced him to... Sarah Gonzales... well, there was some genetic manipulation involved there.

Marie 7A: Go on.

Marie 12F: I synthesized a serum taken from several demonic succubi, and after wiping Sarah's memory, programmed her to be the perfect woman. Once she was injected with the serum, she was the ultimate distraction for him. Of course, he never knew this, and over time I was able to use her in other ways, but I do admit to genetic modification. Just, not with Jason Hiro.

Marie 7A: Sarah Gonzales... that name is oddly familiar. (Adjunct stops the interrogation for a full minute to review notes on her datapad.) Curious, she's listed several times as a potential lover for Jason Hiro, in many universes, but the information is strictly forbidden from a Source universe. How did you conclude that she was the ideal female for your pet project?

Marie 12F: What if I told you it was a lucky guess?

Marie 7A: Don't mock me. This is not a joke; the multiverse itself is at stake.

Marie 12F: Fine, fine. Gods, I got the information from a colleague at the Temporal Council. I was hoping Jason might have a person he shared a bond with across several universes. I thought it might help with my research, and it did!

Marie 7A: Which Marie gave you this information?

Marie 12F: What are you going to do to her if I tell you?

Marie 7A: Do you honestly care for her well-being?

Marie 12F: Not really. Just curious, I suppose. She's Marie 114G.

Marie 7A: Noted. This is a breach of security, but we'll worry about that later. Anything you'd like to admit to before we continue?

Marie 12F: Not that I know of.

Marie 7A: Let's get back to clones. Via Wordsmithing, Jason can make clones of himself. Clones, however, start off as mindless beings, and only if you order them to be sentient will they gain the ability to move of their own accord. However, as noted in a few historical records, clones are sentient even before being allowed free-movement. They frequently become hostile once freed, with rare exception.

Marie 12F: Okay...

Marie 7A: As you've said before, you reviewed the memory footage taken from Jason X. However, it would seem you didn't examine much of it in detail.

Marie 12F: No, unfortunately. I only had a few hours before Jason X arrived in his office. I was also busy finding out from my resurrected colleague, Benjamin Brown, that he had just betrayed me. It was a turbulent time.

Marie 7A: Of course. Well, we've spent the last several days poring over every second of his memory, and here is where I have to be very serious. We suspect there is another Wordsmith in your universe, one other than Jason X and Jason 12F.

Marie 12F: You do? I can see how your questioning would lead up to that, but haven't I proven that can't be the case?

Marie 7A: It would seem so, but this has only made our conclusions murkier. In Jason X's memories, he conducted a few key conversations with Yama, the Second Emperor of Hell, and the content of those conversations was quite disturbing. Yama spoke, specifically, about an 'army of wordsmiths' that Jason would have to face if the humans found him. Don't you find that odd?

Marie 12F: That's weirdly specific of him to say, sure, but Yama is an observed liar. He broke peace treaties on many occasions, including thousands of years ago when he threatened to engulf a planet in my system with his darkness. I even came across him saying that I put bombs inside the brains of human scientists, though it had honestly never occurred to me. Not a bad idea, though.

Marie 7A: A liar, yes, that is true. However, every lie usually has a grain of truth in it. Yama not only spoke of an army of cloned wordsmiths, but he knew intimate details of how wordsmithing functions. Furthermore, Yama sent Beelzebub to teach Jason X how wordsmithing worked. Given that Bael was also at the table, it's likely that all the Demon Emperors know this information.

Marie 12F: I see. So in the end, someone is feeding them information about Wordsmithing. However, Yama can listen to conversations wherever there is darkness. This is why I keep all discussions of a sensitive nature limited to rooms flooded with anti-energy. Perhaps, just by observing Jason 12F, he was able to learn of Wordsmithing's intricacies. Though, I *did* tell Jason to never Wordsmith unless necessary.

Marie 7A: Yama's knowledge extended well beyond anything Jason 12F might know. Once again, I ask you, did you ever give information to Jason 12F that might indicate he could clone himself or others via Wordsmithing?

Marie 12F: (Subject appears visibly stressed.) Of course not! I didn't even know for sure it was a possibility until you told me a few minutes ago! God damn, I need a cigarette. This is stressful.

Marie 7A: I apologize, but we don't offer any illegal drugs on this station.

Marie 12F: Illegal drugs? You're a Marie! We all love cig-

Marie 7A: Let's move on. The final piece of this puzzle was confirmed by an agent we sent to your universe yesterday. She successfully recovered a sample of material from Danis Thornum's corpse. We are, of course, referring to the Danis Thornum who was murdered by Jason X's servant girl, 'Lora'. Based on material recovered from his corpse, biological markers saved in your databases from his recent physical checkup, and memories taken from Jason X's mind... we have confirmed that Jason X cloned Danis Thornum.

Marie 12F: Cloned him? What do you mean?

Marie 7A: The girl that followed Jason X around, the slave he recovered from Yama's domain, murdered Danis when he went into the Labyrinth for vulgar purposes. Jason cloned Danis, and then sent Danis to be a spy among humanity. Based on Jason X's memory of the second time this Lora girl killed Danis, her murder of Danis was an unintended event.

Marie 12F: So... you're saying... Danis was already dead? I mean, that day, he did appear to be slower than usual. I didn't think much of it, but now that you mention it...

Marie 7A: There's more. Yama never told Jason X the specifics of how cloning would work, yet Jason seemed to understand the process on an innate level, according to his memory files. He knew that he had to order Danis to become sentient. The implications are quite serious.

Marie 12F: Let me see if I understand. Jason X is a Source Jason, or at least we suppose he is, but he possesses knowledge that even I don't... Yama knows details of Wordsmithing that he absolutely shouldn't, and you suspect that Jason 12F or I am somehow to blame?

Marie 7A: Given the short amount of time we've put into this case, we have many possible theories. I won't go over them all. A working theory though is that somehow, Jason 12F learned of other universes, created the clone currently known as Jason X, and then Jason 12F erased his own memory of the cloning process. If that were true, even your memory manipulation machine wouldn't find the memories.

Marie 12F: (Subject crosses her arms and leans back in her chair.)...I'm sorry, but that's a stupid theory. Trust me, I know Jason 12F very well. He wouldn't do something like that.

Marie 7A: So you say. In any case, we have enough information to continue our investigation. You've been a big help, Marie 12F.

Marie 12F: Am I free to go?

Marie 7A: Technically yes, but you can't return to your universe just yet. The final reason we've brought you here is to reiterate, one more time, the grave danger that Jason X represents, not just to your little universe, but the multiverse as a whole. A Wordsmith is already a temporal threat by himself, but if he should take control and initiate a war against the Volgrim, they could unleash their ultimate weapon a third time. The Temporal Council cannot overstate the importance that this Jason's mysteries be unveiled, and soon.

Marie 12F: I know you won't answer my question, but I have to try. What is the Volgrim secret weapon that you're so worried about?

Marie 7A: I don't even know myself. Only the highest level Maries are allowed to know, along with Jason Alpha. Take care, Marie 12F, and you should learn to keep that curiosity in check.

Marie 12F: Is that possible? We *are* Maries, after all.

Marie 7A: Very true.

Part 419b: Kolvaxian

"To my loyal followers, humanity's hard working citizens, and the brave soldiers of the United Earth Federation's military... I thank you all for watching this broadcast today. As you all know by now, one month ago I began a series of revisions to the way we live, to bring greater peace and prosperity to our mighty empire! Indeed, we are unstoppable; a force none can oppose! The demons have been reduced to little more than a nuisance, and the Volgrim eye us warily."

I clear my throat and smile at the broadcasting equipment. All it reminds me of is a small black dimple on the wall, but from what I've seen of the recording quality, the image is quite stunning. My words are being broadcast live to every citizen of humanity's empire who wishes to watch. Viewscreens everywhere transmit my face and words to hundreds of trillions of people all at once. Fighting demons is one thing, but public speaking is my Kryptonite.

"Despite the vast resources and overwhelming power of our empire, I have heard the murmuring and the wailing of my people! The food is bitter, energy is scarce, and many are unhappy. I understand. One month ago, I took a long, hard look at what humanity is capable of. With help from our greatest minds, I have undertaken the most magnificent project our civilization will ever see. My goal is simple: I wish to make life better for ALL citizens."

I quickly glance at my datapad and make sure I've got my notes in order.

"First on my itinerary is food. I'll be *blunt*. The food we consume is awful! Terrible! Nutrition bars recycled from our filth! Of course, every citizen is familiar with humanity's creed: *For glory, we aspire. Perfection, we achieve. Waste, we prevent. Failure, we despise*. This motto has shaped the path that humanity has taken for millions of years, and it shall continue to do so! However, I believe most would be hard pressed to justify it as an unbreakable rule in *every* context. Therefore! The first thing I have begun to do is create a new terraforming project. Behold! Planet Kaplis, in the Rygarian system! The second of three planets, Kaplis will complement the animal reservations of Rygar and become a world we can grow far more food on for humanity!"

Kaplis is going to be a planet where we do nothing but grow food en-masse. We won't even need animals to live there, nor bugs, bees, or anything else. Apparently, nanobots and bio-engineering can speed the processes up to a hundred-fold, yielding corn and other plants in a fraction as much time as it would have taken in the era I came from.

The future is truly a place of wonder.

"But food is just one issue I have heard the citizenry criticize. Energy is scarce, and my fellow humans have to slave away just to get enough for themselves. However, we have begun not one, but TWO major Dyson sphere projects that should be completed within the next ten years. These spheres will boost humanity's energy production dramatically! No more haggling for items with a few meager energy credits! No more spending thousands of credits just for a chance to enter Heaven!"

I shoot a glance over at Ben. He's sitting in a chair offscreen, shaking his head. Of course, he doesn't like my last proclamation in the slightest, but I've already spoken to the archangel Gabriel. With his permission, I know it's going to succeed.

"We have lost many loved ones. Even I am not immune to this loss. However, being the Supreme Commander has always had one perk, which is the ability to visit Heaven whenever I please. But why should only an elite few hold this privilege? Surely, anyone who wishes to see a loved one should not be held back by lack of energy credits! With help from my best ambassadors, I have created a new immigration treaty between human and angelkind! Starting immediately, anyone will be able to visit Heaven as they please, and angels will be able to visit human-owned planets as they wish. Truly, we are blessed to live in a time of such abundance!"

I have to hold myself back from chuckling. The solutions to humanity's problems were so *easy*. Marie was the supposed inventor of all humanity's systems, and she guided legislation along with her pet, Jason 12F, but the society she created is grossly unpleasant. The food is terrible, the energy scarce, and aside from immortality and a second chance at living if one should die, it has more drawbacks than upsides compared to the time I came from.

Honestly, living in this empire is more of an eternal curse than anything resembling a utopia. It's high time someone took advantage of advancements in technology to improve life for all.

"Everything is going to change, citizens. I assure you, from this day forward, humanity will begin marching toward a new dawn."

* * *

Oh god... he's dead... I killed him! I mean, I was supposed to kill him. This is fine; he was evil! He supported demons, just like Danis did!

I feel weak in my legs. For a moment I almost want to vomit, but I hold the feeling down and lean against a wall to support myself. *DNA*. Amy said I couldn't leave DNA behind. I snapped his neck cleanly, just like she told me to, so there's no blood and he didn't even fight back.

He didn't even fight back?! I don't feel right about this. Danis killed my friend, and the guards at the prison were trying to kill me! I had to kill them first, right? Self-defense. Isn't that what I'm supposed to do? What would Master say? Is killing someone who wasn't trying to hurt

me okay? Doesn't killing someone who doesn't fight back make me the bad guy? Oh lord... I need to get out of here.

Right! Snap out of it, Lora! Use your head!

I quickly turn back to the window I left open when I entered his suite. The senator lived really high up, but the invisibility belt Steven gave me and the climbing gear made scaling this tower easy. I'm just... not looking forward to climbing 3,000 stories back down. There aren't any cameras on the outside of the building, but all the hallways inside are monitored. If I walk out the door, even invisible, I'm sure to be spotted by something.

Quickly I hop over to the window but pause and glance at a wall to my right. There's a video playing on the viewscreen, and I instantly recognize the person on the screen. It's Master!

"...*we are unstoppable; a force none can oppose.*" Master's voice is like music to my ears! I haven't seen him in a whole month, but I have to see him soon. He looks the same as when I last talked to him... is he still angry at me? Is he even looking for me anymore?

Maybe I angered him, after all. He might never forgive me. Steven and Amy say that he's working with the demons, just like Danis. If he's working with demons, is that why Yama liked him so much? But then, why was Master ready to kill Danis? Were they enemies? If they were enemies, why did Master make a clone of Danis?

My head hurts!! Everything is so confusing. I have to see him, I have to! But not right now. I have a job to do. I have to kill the bad people, and I have to escape safely.

Quickly, I hop out the window, and my hands stick to the outer walls. The wind howls past me and looking down makes my stomach flip-flop. I can't see the ground below, only a murky image of brown clouds through the air-mask Amy gave me to wear. It's pressed so closely to my face, but somehow it makes the sheer drop seem less terrifying.

I'm still scared of heights though.

I pull the window back into place behind me, shuffle over to the right a bit, and quickly start climbing down, one foot and hand after the other.

This is going to take *forever*!

* * *

The video feed cuts off, and I breathe a long sigh of relief. Despite calming myself with Wordsmithing, it only provided me an artificial method of denying my anxiety. The moment I 'normalize' myself, I'll probably turn into a shaky mess.

Ben walks over to me and grunts, a hint of disapproval in his voice. "Great speech."

"You don't really think that, do you?"

A chuckle. "No no, the speech *was* great. You delivered it like a well-trained hovercar salesman. My problem is with the contents, not the delivery."

I roll my eyes and summon a can of grape soda in front of me, checking to make sure nobody's watching first. "Come off it, Ben. I know you love Marie and the way she does things, but didn't you ever think that just *maybe* the life of regular humans could be improved?"

"Of course I did. I'm the one who showed you the lower levels, after all. I just think you're taking it too far, too fast."

The grape soda pours down my throat and leaves a refreshing tingling feeling behind. I stifle a burp and grin sheepishly. "Too fast, huh? What, you think the politicians have the guts to stand up to me? I dare them to try."

"You sound a little resentful." Ben offers a less than neutral opinion.

I shrug. "Maybe I'm still pissed. I might be new to this society, but I see how the politicians rig the game in their favor. I didn't like politicians back before I froze myself, and I don't like them now. Things need to change."

Ben nods and glances down at the datapad in his hands. "I understand that. I just think that if you change too many things all at once, you're going to incur resentment from many of the-huh?"

"What?" I stop just before drinking another gulp of soda. "Did something happen?"

"Uh. Yes." Ben focuses intently for a few seconds on the pad in his hand. "I can't believe this. The crime and justice division received an anonymous tip-off shortly after your broadcast concluded. Someone killed Lawrence Phesbin. They snapped his goddamn neck."

"Who?"

Ben shakes a dazed look from his face. "Lawrence was the vice president of the Corvallis Sector. He was a fairly popular anti-war politician, known for advocating peace with demonkind. In fact, he was essentially second in command for maintaining development of three separate star systems. A very prestigious job, even among upper-class citizens."

"Yeah. He sounds really important." I swish the soda around in the can. It's already half-gone. "So who killed him?"

"Well, we have to perform an investigation first. You should be aware... murder has been almost entirely eliminated. Humans don't kill their own kind."

"Not that you know of." I make a point to correct him. "Still, maybe it wasn't a human. Why not a demon?"

Ben immediately gives me a sardonic look. "Lawrence was a pro-demon politician and was known for advocating peace with them. I highly doubt a demon would do this."

Ben's instant disbelief makes me question if he isn't being conservative. "Have you ever spent time with the demons?"

"No."

"Demons are odd, really odd. Maybe this Lawrence guy learned something he shouldn't have. I could see Yama knocking him off. The only suspect thing is the neck-snapping part. I feel like a demon would use magic or something, not their bare hands."

"Yeah, possibly. This is a small crisis, but it's not that bad. We'll just wait for more information." Ben sighs and quickly tucks the datapad back in his pocket. "I just can't believe it. Either a human killed another human, which is unthinkable, or a demon turned against a pro-demon politician."

"If he was pro-demon, what do you think the odds were he was visiting Yama's domain to pass the time?"

My question makes Ben's face contort in disgust. "I should hope not. I still have many people I'd like to respect, you know."

"I wonder. I know Yama, and I couldn't see him inviting humans to his lair for the secret thrills ordinary human society can't give them... not without demanding they pay the price. Yama has spies among the humans. He's something else." My hand falls and rests on Blaarjiim's orb, still invisible and tucked at my side. Nobody knows about him yet, and I've managed to keep him a secret from Ben. I'm beginning to wonder if the orb isn't also a way for Yama to keep tabs on me. Very clever, if that's the case.

Ben stands up and walks over to the door, brushing the dust off his shoulderpad in the process. "I need to go. I'll let you know if anything else comes up. But I'm warning you, Jason... I think you're moving too fast with the reformation acts. It's going to bite you in the ass."

"Yeah yeah, you've said that enough times." I watch him shuffle over to the door, and a question sprouts in my mind. *Why the sudden rush?*

"See you later." Ben nods and walks through the door, leaving me alone with just my thoughts.

I wonder if it was Yama who killed that vice-president guy... or *someone else*. If I weren't so busy, I'd go have a look myself.

Well, back to work I go. At least I've got Sarah waiting at home tonight. That'll make this crappy day all better again.

* * *

"Squad Leader Hiro, no biological contaminants in my sector." Rika's demure voice comes over loud and clear in my earpiece. "Moving two clicks to the north-east."

"I'm still looking. Keep your eyes peeled, and don't leave the group for any solo adventures." I grunt the words out and can almost hear her straining to understand my words. This jungle hurts me, deep in my chest. It's not so much toxins in the air as it is a strange, dark energy pervading the air.

My other squad sub-commander confirms his position next. "Northwest is also clear, Squad Leader. No Kolvaxians to be seen."

"That's just the way they want you thinking, Ricky. You and Milo keep your backs to each other. This jungle makes my head woozy."

I stumble slightly, and my foot jams down into a five-inch thick puddle of brown glop. I'd call it mud, but it's thick like a parfait. I have to use my magical flight to pull myself out of it and back onto solid ground. The foliage around me is so thick I could hack it to bits with a white hot Vibro-sword, and more vines would just roll down from the canopy above.

The trees of Morius aren't like the trees from Earth, my home planet. I haven't seen Earth since the Kolvaxians devoured it, ten million years ago. They're a violent species, something like a mixture of plant and human, and created from god-knows-what-hell somewhere deep in space. Marie thinks they're interesting. My universe is the only one that has these freaks, but we don't know how they appeared. Having cut down far too many in combat, I know only one thing for sure: they aren't *entirely* alien. Marie believes they're descended from Volgrim genetic trials. That might be the case, except the Kolvaxians haven't shown up in any universe but this one.

Makes a person think, eh?

Rika whispers something, and I don't quite catch it. "What was that? Come in, Red Squad?"

She clears her throat. "Sorry, Squad Leader. I was just thinking out loud. When do we get our next vacation?"

Ricky chuckles over the mic. "Nice, Rika. Way to get your head in the game."

"Ricky's right. this isn't the time for asking about vacations." I chide her gently, though I haven't been able to spend much time with her either. All we do these days is chase leads from one assimilated planet to the next. "I'll put in a request though if you need some time off."

I smile in spite of this grim situation and wait for her response. Nothing happens. "Ehh, Rika? Did you copy that?"

Silence. A few seconds pass and my blood chills. "Ricky, you still there?"

"Y-yeah, Squad Leader." Ricky's voice is tense. "Loren? Rika? Do you two copy your Squad Leader, over?"

My breath comes in raspy gulps. "Son of a bitch. **Teleport.** "

I arrive at their last known location and quickly let out a sonic pulse around my body, in case there's an ambush lying in wait. Nothing happens.

"Daughters of the devil." I curse at myself for not paying closer attention. In the mud at my feet, two bloody helmets lie, covered in what I can only describe to myself as 'brain matter'. "Ricky, jump to me. We have-" I pause to catch my breath and not let myself sound choked up. "-we have hits in the north-east. They got Rika and Loren."

Ricky and Jeremiah pop over next to me in the blink of an eye. I can't see their faces inside the tinted glass of their containment suits, but their posture tells me they already get the picture.

"Boss... can't you locate them?"

Ricky's question makes my chest sting. "No, son. This forest has plenty of interference. My telepathy was locked on them the whole time, but I didn't even notice them gone until I got here. They're dead."

"You have to try!" Ricky grabs my shoulder, but I bat his hand away.

" **Locate.** " Seconds pass, no hits. "There. I tried."

Even with the containment suit on, I can see his hands shaking. "K... Kolvaxian... scum." The words are squeezed out through gritted teeth.

"Remember that anger. Keep on the alert. The fuckers are around here somewhere. Let's pay them back ten times over!" I float in the air several feet above the ground and aim my mind all around me. " **Expansion!** "

A wave of energy surges outward, blasting the foliage and tree cover away. My suit lights up with an alert. "Bogeys spotted! Position 141.3!"

I barely even have time to process them. A flash of ugly deep green skin, boils and pus all over their bodies, and those eerie, unseeing eyes. Kolvaxian, for sure.

The four-armed mutant sucks down into the ground and vanishes from sight. "They're compatible with the floor cover! Go to flight mode!"

My final two squaddies jump up into the air and their suit thrusters ignite, keeping them aloft. Just in time too, as the green plant-monster hybrid pops out of the ground where they had just been standing. They don't have emotions, but based on its movements, I'd almost say it's confused.

"You like the taste of human, eh?! Have a lick of this!" I smash down, using my telekinesis to hurl myself at the ground with surprising force. I crash into the Kolvaxian with my whole body, splattering it all over the place in a single instant. " **Contain!** " I lash out and grab the central 'heart', a pulsing rock that is the life-force of these monsters, and jam it into a containment bubble for safekeeping.

"Good work, Squad Leader." Jeremiah's words of praise ring hollow. There's no soul to what he's saying. He and Ricky lower down, landing on the ground behind me. Staying aloft for so long is bound to make them run their fuel out quickly. "You got him."

"Yeah, I did. It's not good enough though, is it?"

"Don't... don't blame yourself, Jason. Rika wouldn't want that. Neither would Loren." Ricky tries to pat me on the back, but I pull away.

"It happened so fast. I knew I shouldn't have split the five of us up."

I turn around, the heart of the Kolvaxian hovering in the air before me, and realize Ricky and Jeremiah's heads are both bowed slightly.

"We all share this sin. Let's go, Jason. We can't mope around forever."

"Yeah." The three of us walk the way we came, and I glance back uneasily. "Where there's one Kolvaxian, there's more. They have two more hosts now, too."

Even as I say this, the inside of my helmet lights up. A call is being broadcast to me. I know who it is even before I see their face.

"Jason 10K. What are you doing right now?"

"What's your identifier?"

I'm kind of annoyed she didn't open with her identifier. That's common protocol, makes these conversations a whole lot less messy. My day's already bad enough now... she doesn't need to make it worse.

"Don't you recognize me? I'm Marie 7A." Her stupid fake cheerful smile makes me want to punch her fucking face.

"Oh, sorry, I just had two close friends die, *Marie*. What bullshit do you want to pull me away for now? I've got the Kolvaxians pinned down on Morius-"

"Forget the Kolvaxians. You have bigger things to worry about." Marie cuts me off mid-sentence without a care in the world. "Sorry about your friend, but this concerns the integrity of the multiverse itself. We're recalling all Kilo branch and higher Jasons to a meeting regarding recent findings we've made."

"Oh, great. I just barely made the cut. I couldn't be happier." I try not to let *too* much disgust seep into my voice, but she ignores my feeble protests anyway.

"Get here in the next five hours. That's an order from the Alpha branch. Marie 7A out."

Her face disappears, and I couldn't be happier she's gone.

"Fucking bitch. I have a funeral to attend."

I suddenly realize the other two are looking at me. "You okay, Jason?" Ricky's voice has a tinge of worry in it. "You've been standing there for a solid minute, saying nothing."

"Sorry, Ricky. After we make our peace with Rika and Loren... I need to go on a trip."

He nods slowly and turns away. "Rika would want that. You deserve the vacation."

No, he's wrong. I don't deserve anything.

Part 420b: (◀▶~◀▶)

My footsteps echo down the tiled halls as I walk toward the dining room. When I open the door, I smile politely at all the familiar faces. I've been living among these people for a month now, and while I don't know much about them other than their names, they seem pleasant enough. Two girls sitting at the bar spot me and wave at me. *Hi Lora!* I see their mouths move, but the music playing over to the right by the live jazz band makes it hard to hear them say the words.

I can't return the smile. I haven't gotten over what I did. I killed a man, one who didn't fight back. Even if he had, it wasn't a fair fight. He didn't have a weapon, and he didn't know how to fight. How could I do that? What's wrong with me? Killing someone to protect my friends, and killing another to protect myself, those are very different things compared to killing someone just because Mr. Feldmann told me to. I have to speak to him. I can't kill anyone else. It's wrong!

I quickly turn away from the two at the bar and sweep my gaze across the room. My trained eyes spot him sitting in a corner, just barely visible behind a short wall. He's talking to a young woman, possibly my age, wearing a professional-looking white shirt and black skirt. I haven't seen her before, but the look on his face tells me it's a professional meeting. I can barely tell from the back of her head, but she keeps reaching up to brush hair out of her eyes. It looks like she's angling to get something from him, but I don't know what.

I walk toward them slowly, my enhanced hearing carefully tuning into their conversation as the jazz band fades away behind me.

"-what I said! I've been keeping an eye on him as you instructed, but so far he's just doing normal things. He never deviates from his daily schedule." She bows her head as her voice is tinged with an apologetic tone, and Steven smiles pleasantly at her.

"Right. Well, I am sorry to keep hounding you like this, Stephanie. I know you're doing your best, just as I trained you, but I need results. He wouldn't fire you for no reason, understand?"

The girl, apparently named 'Stephanie,' wipes at her eye. "It's just so frustrating. I keep flashing back in my mind to what he said. He called me untrustworthy! He must have known. It couldn't be a coincidence."

I keep walking, and soon I'm only ten feet away. Steven notices me out of the corner of his eye. "Lora! You're back! I'm just having a chat here with a colleague of mine." He smiles at her

again, but I feel like there's a hint of something else in his eye. "Stephanie, this is Lora, the studious young woman I was telling you about."

She turns back to me, and I finally get a look at her face, having looked at the back of her head the whole way here. The best way I'd describe her face is... *plain*. It doesn't stand out and looks like the faces of many slave girls I've known. I'd have trouble picking her out of a crowd. "So you must be Lora, hmm? We're here under similar circumstances. I lost my job, and Steven helped me out when my luck was down. Just like he did with you!" She stands up from the chair and turns back to Steven. "Anyway, I imagine you need to talk to your agent over here, so I'll be heading out. Call me later?"

"Of course. Have a pleasant day, Steph." Steven nods, and she brushes past me and walks away.

I, on the other hand, can barely even care about whatever they were talking about. Steven's expectant stare makes my stomach flip-flop. I feel queasy just looking at him.

"Is the deed done? Did you hit the mark?" Steven's smile is replaced with a more casual stare, almost of disinterest.

"Um... y-yes... I killed him. He's dead. I... I didn't leave any DNA." I stutter and feel even more embarrassed, so I quickly plop down where Stephanie had been sitting and rest my hands on my knees, grimacing when I feel them trembling. "He didn't fight back. He- he *couldn't* manage even a feeble resistance. It was quick. I hope it was painless."

Steven stares at me for a few seconds, and his expression becomes more serious. My heart quickens, and I have to look away from him. Water. I need water.

"You don't look so stable. Are you okay, Lora? Do you feel guilty about killing him?" Steven's soft voice makes me blush. I shake my head quickly, but he continues anyway. "You did the right thing. He was working with the demons. Just like Danis."

"Bar... bartender. Water, please. Water." I grit my teeth and tap the counter nervously. Steven is still staring at me, and it's making me feel uncomfortable. "It's not okay, Mr. Feldmann. *I'm* not okay. I killed an innocent m-man."

Before I realize it, he leans forward and touches my arm. "Hey... hey, you look disturbed about this. If I'd known you didn't want to do it, I wouldn't have asked, okay? I shouldn't have told you to kill him. I'm sorry." He pulls back and finally turns his gaze away. "I just... I thought that if you had already killed a hundred men, plus the warden, plus Danis, and twice for him... I thought you were a steadfast person. But now I see I was selfish."

The bartender sets the glass of water down, and I grab and gulp it as quick as I can, only to accidentally choke. It takes a few seconds, but I manage to cough and get my bearings.

Steven's disappointed. Of course he is! I've already killed a hundred people. It's like he said, and now I'm getting wishy-washy over... over one demon collaborator?!

But even if I think like that, it doesn't make me feel any better. "I'm sorry, Mr. Feldmann. I can't kill people anymore. I took his life, and I didn't even know him! It... it wasn't fair. He couldn't even fight back, and now he'll never see his family again. He's gone... forever."

"Huh?" Steven suddenly exhales loudly. "Ahh, so that's what it was. You- I haven't told you about angels yet, have I?"

I'm so confused. What's he talking about now? I turn to look at him, and the serious look is gone, replaced by a faint smile. "Mr. Feldmann? What do angels have to do with anything?"

He scratches his facial stubble. "I'm surprised you don't know. You pray every morning, right? Don't you know why humans are mandated to pray?"

A moment later, I remember what Marie told me when I stayed with her a month ago. "We have to pray because if we die, we'll be reborn as angels."

"Uh huh..." Steven's smile grows a little wider. "And, therefore, if every human is praying, and you kill a person, then what happens?"

"He's... he's not dead?"

"Exactly." The smile vanishes as quickly as it came. "I didn't tell you this, Lora, because I thought you already knew. When you killed Lawrence, he died and became an angel. Humans who are reborn as angels are never allowed to work in government or ever be a member of human society ever again. It might seem cruel, but you've cut off his influence from our government. Now his pro-demon sentiment will stop infecting our civilization."

Steven leans forward and raises an eyebrow. "Honestly, you did that man a favor. By becoming an angel, he is now living among all his family members who have ever died, and he no longer has to work all the time. He doesn't have to eat the awful nutrition bars or do all those annoying things humans hate doing anyway. You improved his life. I'm sure he'd thank you if he could."

My hands finally stop shaking, and the pit in my stomach eases up. "Is that the truth? I improved his life?"

Steven reaches for a drink at the counter, probably something alcoholic, as he prefers. "Indeed. Heck, he has a nice pair of wings now, and he can fly around at his leisure. I'm a little envious."

"Wow. I never realized..." I lean back in my chair against the short wall dividing Steven's private section of the dining room from the rest of the people here and breathe a little easier. "If being an angel is so wonderful, why doesn't everyone become an angel?"

Steven shakes his head and sighs. "You know, Lora... life isn't always a simple question of 'why' or 'why not.' The government, led by my father, keeps certain information from the vast majority of the citizenry. He also feeds false information to them as well. For example, most people, in particular among the lower levels, don't know that angels have no requirement to eat food. We do say that angels can never enjoy the taste of food, but it's a half-truth at best."

He continues. "We keep a lot of things from them. We have to. That's just the way it is. If all of humanity realized how much better it would be to live life as an angel, what do you suppose would happen?"

"They'd kill themselves?"

"Exactly. The angels need humans to pray because angels will die without our thought energy. If the human population declines significantly, the angels won't have enough energy to go around. A lot of them would die, and that would defeat the purpose of the contract we signed. It's not good for us, and bad for them."

A silly question comes to mind. "Even if the lower-class people don't know, you do. You could kill yourself and become an angel. Why don't you?"

He shakes his head immediately and looks me square in the eyes. "There aren't a lot of good people out there, Lora. What do you think would happen if I died? This building, the people in it," He waves his hand around to emphasize. "they'd stop functioning. There would be no active resistance to the pro-demon factions that, thanks to you, I now know run our government. I can't drop out like that. I can't just take the easy way out."

"I'm sorry. I didn't mean anything by it."

Steven continues to stare at me for a few seconds before turning back to his alcohol. "Yes, I know. Anyway, just get this sadness for Lawrence out of your head, okay? He's an angel now, living a better life than he was before, and he isn't causing trouble for ordinary people anymore. You did well."

"Okay." I nod slowly, and a few moments later I get that sinking feeling in my stomach again. "Mr. Feldmann..."

"Saint Joseph, didn't I tell you to call me by my first name when we're in private like this? You're putting me on edge."

I ignore his protests. "You said all humans pray, and because of this, they all become angels when they die... right?"

"Uh huh. Sounds about right."

"Then, does that include Danis? The Warden? All the men I killed?"

He turns to look at me seriously once more. "Yes. Does that bother you?"

"What if I... what if I kill an angel? What happens then?"

He cricks his neck and sighs. "Then they're dead for good. And yes, in case you're wondering, Danis and everyone else you've killed are all angels now. I've seen their personnel files." His breath catches in his throat. "Why are you asking? Are you going to break through the warp-gate, enter Heaven, and kill them?"

"No. No! Of course not! I- I was just asking."

My defiant tone doesn't persuade him. "Yeah, if you say so. I won't hold it against you either way." A moment later he reaches down and picks up his datapad. "By the way, this is your next target. If you're done moping over Lawrence Phesbin, you should be antsy to knock this guy off. He's a known human trafficker. We believe he's working with the demons too. He might even be..." He pauses for a moment. "...well, he might be sending other girls to Yama. I hope you don't have any qualms killing bottom-feeding scum like him."

I take the datapad from Steven and stare at the man's chiseled face silently. "No. None at all. Is he going to become an angel too?"

Steven nods as I hand him the datapad back. "Sadly, yes. In my opinion, some people don't deserve such a reward."

There's a long silence as I swallow and try to gather my thoughts, and finally, I stand up to leave. "I'll be going now."

Steven nods but doesn't say anything. I start to walk away, but he grabs my hand. "Lora. Before you go, have you heard what my father is doing, right now?"

I blush as Stevens' hand slides down mine, rolling off my fingertips. "No... what?"

"He's creating a new law that will open up Heaven, allowing angels and humans to leave and enter Heaven as they please. Unlimited travel. Do you know what that means?"

My stomach churns. My voice is a whisper. "Danis... the Warden..."

"They might come looking for you. I wonder why my father is doing that now, of all times?"

My body feels cold. "I have to go."

"Take care." Steven turns back to the table and averts his eyes from mine. A void appears between us as I turn and walk away.

I'm going to be sick.

* * *

I can't look weak now. I put one foot in front of the other and stride forth into the main throne room belonging to the King of Gods. Zeus, a god who, I presume, can throw bolts of lightning if the myths are true, sits on his royal throne and stares silently at me as I confidently head toward him.

Gabriel steps out from the right-hand side of his king and bows before me, and I return the gesture, both toward him, and again to Zeus. "Welcome, Supreme Commander Jason Hiro, to the King's Hall, the most sacred of places here in Heaven. King Zeus, as well as myself, welcome you with open arms."

Zeus stands from his chair and walks a few steps toward me. "Indeed, Master Hiro, we are honored that you would come to see us in our home." He stands staring at me for a moment, but before I can greet him as well, he lunges forward and wraps his arms around me, embracing me in a bear hug that I quickly reciprocate. "My old friend! It's good to not have other stuffy bureaucrats around during times like these!"

"Yeah, King Zeus, I'm glad to see you too." I return the hug awkwardly, wondering to myself if this is normal behavior. He pulls away after a few moments to what I would consider a more appropriate arms-length distance.

Out of the corner of my eye, I spot Gabriel rolling his eyes, but he notices me looking and stiffens quickly, pretending it never happened. It's funny; I get a distinct impression that Zeus is a more touchy-feely ruler than Gabriel would like him to be.

Zeus looks me up and down. "I presume you're here for business purposes, and not for matters of a personal nature."

I nod diplomatically. "Yes, afraid so. A Supreme Commander's work is never done."

Zeus gestures to a pew several feet from his throne, allowing me to sit down as he returns to his throne, sighing contentedly. "Right you are! My work is always moving, never allowing me rest. Still, I was quite surprised by the motion you forwarded through Gabriel. I would usually expect a tremendous request like this to come directly to me." He procures a scroll from a table beside his throne and unrolls it neutrally. "You wish to open up the borders and allow humans and angels to move freely between our worlds, eh?"

"I meant no disrespect, King Zeus. I was just in a rush and hoped to speak with you about the matter later."

Zeus rolls up the paper quickly and sets it back on the table. "Ha ha! Tis' not any great offense. You're here now, and I presume to discuss the terms of this border opening, eh?"

"That's right." My lips purse as I examine the eyes of the Greek god before me. Zeus, a god so fearsome he killed his father in mortal combat. Are myths and legends true? Do other gods exist? Other angels? I know precious little of the hierarchy at work in this dimension, but I must understand it better if I am to make it work for me.

"King Zeus," I lean forward a little bit. "as a long-lived friend of mine, I seek not just your approval, but your advice today."

"Oh? Advice?"

"Yes. I have been looking at the plight my fellow humans are in, and I wish to alleviate their discomforts and their sorrows. I am going to start by increasing energy production, creating food that will satisfy them in a way nutrition bars cannot, and, with your permission, allow them to meet and speak with their long-since deceased loved ones."

Zeus widens his eyes. "It sounds to me as if you have this all planned out. How could I be of assistance to you?"

"Do you have any suggestions for how I could make human society more pleasant?"

My question makes him pause for several long moments. His gaze drifts away as he gives my request much thought. "As a god, I know little of how humans perceive the world. Indeed, my experience is different even from the angels I lead. I cannot offer help here. I do not know the taste of food, nor the pleasure of a sexual escapade. Humans are humans, angels are angels, and I am me. I will not be of service to you in this matter."

I feel slightly stupid for even asking. "Sorry, it was a silly request on my part."

"No no, it was quite alright. Anything for you." Zeus strokes his long, golden beard. "Now, that being said, I would like to finally take time to discuss that matter I spoke of with you when last we met."

I feel blank on the inside. "Ah, that would be...?"

"The increase in the human birthing limits. I asked you the last time we spoke if you could allow one to two percent of the population to have a child. The increase in thought-energy output would greatly help my people continue to live adequate lives."

Ah. Ben explained this to me briefly a short time ago. Angels require thought energy to survive, and thus humans give them the energy whenever they pray. Still, with hundreds of

trillions of humans, and only ten trillion angels or so... you'd think the angels would have more than enough energy to get along just fine.

"You want me to increase the number of humans? That's a tall order. I could certainly do it, but I would want to wait until my reforms have come into effect."

"Ah. I see. Tell me, is humanity stretched too thin, currently? Are you running out of food and natural resources? Perhaps there's some way I might help?"

I shake my head at his question. "No, no to both. We have plenty of food, but the food is merely nutrition bars. I am seeking to bring back fruits and vegetables in reasonable quantities."

Zeus and Gabriel both look a little disinterested. Gabriel decides to speak this time. "Are you able to expand humanity's population, then?"

"Yes, absolutely. If you need us to expand, I'm very willing to help. Anything to assist humanity's closest ally." A question forms in my mind. "Forgive me for asking, but given how many humans there are, compared to the number of angels, isn't there enough energy to supply you already?"

For a brief moment, I almost spot Zeus's smile cracking, as if I had activated a secret rage inside of him. It passes instantly, and I wonder if I might have hallucinated it.

"Unfortunately, it is not. Humans have pitifully small amounts of energy within their bodies. It would take ten people donating prayer energy to keep a single pseudo-angel alive, to say nothing of a pureblood or an Archangel, like our friend Gabriel here." Zeus chuckles and nudges the winged swordsman, but Gabriel only bows solemnly.

"It is as the King says, Supreme Commander. To use an allegory, imagine a human who is given a sip of water and a small wafer of bread every day. This may allow him to survive, but he will be quite weak due to malnutrition. For angels of pure and human blood alike, the more energy we are given, the more energy we have in our bodies to move and live. Due to an uptick in the number of recorded deaths over the last several millennia-

Zeus interrupts him. "Especially including that dreadful Goldesh incident, mind you."

Gabriel doesn't appear flustered in the slightest. "-we have had many angels, but no human births to replace them. This would be a good time to restore the energy we've lost by accepting new arrivals, and for upper and middle-level humans to play the lottery and have a chance to create a new generation. Given you're looking to boost morale, this will help you as much as it does us."

He has a point. Ben tells me humans are strictly forbidden from having children without governmental permission, so it must be demoralizing for younger families to have to wait thousands of years and never have children of their own. Then again, I despise most children, but having a son like Timothy would change even a hardened mind like mine.

"Very well. I will speak to those who dictate law among my peers and use the full weight of my authority to push for a new reproduction lottery. I trust you will assist me in creating a new travel system for angels and humans to switch between our realms?"

Gabriel and Zeus look at each other, then back to me. "That will be acceptable."

"Great! I hope that concludes the business part of this meeting." I tap a button on my wrist communicator, and one of my shuttle personnel walks in, holding a box I designed myself with wordsmithing. "What say we have a little fun now? I have this game I brought with me, and I think it might appeal to you."

Zeus licks his lips and leans in closer. "Commander Jason... you don't take me to be a gambler, do you?"

I fold open the box on a table to my side to reveal a backgammon board. "Oh, definitely not. You're much too respectable for that. We're just playing for fun."

"Mmm. I will take the white pieces, then." Zeus quickly gets off his throne and walks over to me, even as Gabriel *tsk tsk's* to himself.

At least this part of my memory was accurate. Zeus *loves* playing games of chance. He and the previous Jason had quite the rivalry going, and it would be in bad form for me to forget that.

"I'll take the dark pieces, then."

Part 421b: Discovery

Lora slides out of her chair and walks away from the bar, leaving only Steven for me to stare at. As she walks away, I notice she has a sad, yet determined look on her face, so whatever they discussed must have been pretty important. Steven stays seated and swirls his half-full glass around absentmindedly, staring at the mirror on the wall in front of him. I can't help but wonder what's going through his mind at times like these.

Well, I'd better find out what they talked about. I gracefully get out of my chair and stroll over, sitting down where Lora had been less than a minute before. Her nearly empty glass of water is still here.

"Looks like you two had a fun chat. She was on the verge of bursting into tears." Steven glances up at me when he hears me speak, then back to his drink.

"You're imagining things, Amy. I'd never make a woman cry. I'm not a monster."

I always feel a little antsy when my hands have nothing to do, so I slide Lora's glass back and forth in front of me. "I've only known you a few hundred years, Steven. Even so, I can tell when something's troubling you. You always pick at the hem of your shirt when you're feeling antsy."

He quickly pulls his hand away from his long sleeves. "No I don't."

"Gotcha."

Both of us share a grin, but his fades in an instant. "It's hard to smile right now. What the hell kind of game is my father playing at? He was always against taking action against the demons, then Lora met him in Yama's domain, and it turns out he was having tea and crumpets with Yama himself!"

"So your father is working with the demons? I mean, it makes sense once we fit all the pieces together..."

Steven shakes his head as a flash of anger crosses over his face. "No, see, that's the thing. My father was there, he wanted to kill Danis himself, but Lora beat him to the punch. So, if he wanted to kill Danis, why would he use a cloning machine to bring him back? And what about Admiral Danis's angelic form? Why haven't we been able to find it?"

"We haven't? But you told me-"

"I stretched the truth a little. I found a record in a system, thanks to one of my spies. Danis did arrive in Heaven, but he was never formally registered. Either he purposefully avoided the registration queue and hid in a corner until someone pulled him out, or... they..."

"...killed him." I release a breath I've been unconsciously holding. "You think he didn't want people to know Danis was dead? What would that achieve?"

"I have my suspicions." Steven takes a sip of his alcohol and pauses, noticing his hand is shaking. "He knew my father was there in Hell. He probably didn't think things through and assumed there would be charges brought against him for conspiring with the demons. Don't you realize what this says about my father?"

"Your father wasn't actually conspiring with the demons?"

"Exactly! That, or Danis and my Father never knew the other was a demon collaborator." Steven clicks his tongue. "He visited the demons, yet he also killed Danis, but then he cloned Danis, yet now he is trying to push through all this new legislation, and he may have had Danis killed again, including his rebirthed angel form. If I assume he's a demon collaborator, then I also have to assume this legislation has a sinister motive behind it. But, for the life of me, it seems mostly good for humanity. We should have passed laws like these sooner, thousands if not millions of years ago. Why did he wait so long?"

I just nod along and make a motion to the bartender, holding up three fingers so he knows what to bring me. The bartender grabs the glass of water in front of me, and moments later he comes back holding plain beer in a thick mug and sets it down. "Maybe you're right, Steven. Maybe there's a ploy behind all these recent political actions. Then again, the new policies could be benign. What if Jason is using them to hide other activities? Maybe there's something worse planned behind the scenes."

Steven's eyes are filled with pain. "I just don't understand how it came to this. My father was always a busy man, strict, a real disciplinarian. He never allowed me or any of my later siblings to call him 'father' or 'dad'. It was always 'sir' when he was in the room. It felt... alienating. Even so, he never was the kind of man who would work with demons to destroy humanity. At least, not that I knew. That's why this is so frustrating for me."

The froth on top of my beer is the best part. I slurp it down quickly, then take a few small sips of the liquid itself. "I know what you mean. There are people I thought I knew well, but it turned out they were not the creatures I had assumed them to be."

"Your daughter." It isn't a question, as he already knows the answer.

"Yeah. She acts like she's forgotten me entirely. Her own mother! Has she forgotten her father too? He was-" My voice catches and I have to stop once I feel a raw emotion tugging at my heart.

Steven quickly reaches over and puts his hand on mine. "Even I know about Jorge. He was a good man."

I pull my hand away quickly. His touch isn't what I want to feel, not right now. "That's... that's why I want, so desperately, for your father to at least pass the unlimited travel law. I can finally see my husband again."

Steven finishes off his drink and slowly spins the glass in front of himself. "We all have people we'd like to see. Even being the son of the Supreme Commander doesn't give me the power to enter Heaven as I please. Still, if my father is planning something evil, we have to stop him. You know that, right?"

"I know what I have to do. Jorge wouldn't want me to give in to evil just to see him again. If I really wanted to see him, there's always the other way."

"Don't even talk like that." A scowl flashes across Steven's face. "Not even as a joke. If I ever find out you killed yourself just to mope about with your husband, I'll break into Heaven and beat your ass."

I can't find the words to say, but Steven cracks a smile out of nowhere. "Heck, you'd probably like that."

"You're such a perv." I shove myself away from the counter and sigh, realizing I barely touched my beer. My appetite is gone now. "I'm going to do some yoga. Don't get too sloshed, Steven. You're not you when you're drunk."

"Sure." Steven glares across the bar at his reflection in the mirror. "Anything you ask, I'll do."

I wonder if he sees something in his reflection that even I don't.

* * *

FINALLY! Some peace and quiet. Good god, I've been working nonstop chatting with these whiny lawyers and politicians, and all they ever do is bitch and complain about this and that. If I want anything, no matter how small, they expect a political kickback or a favor, and I swear ninety percent of their requests are just to see what they can wring from me because I'm the Supreme Commander.

But for now, I am at peace. And just in time, too. Ben isn't hanging around, and even if he wanted to find me, he couldn't.

This is a dimensional space I created. All I had to do was realize that Heaven and Hell are completely outside the 'universe' I know, and I would then understand that creating folded space is a simple matter. This will be a safe area for me. Nobody else knows it exists... except for Blaarjiim and myself, of course.

The demon in the orb yawns as I tap his container. "What is it? Why must you pester me?"

I roll my eyes up at the light surrounding us from all angles. Much like how the Book of Genesis has God create light first and the Sun second, my dimension is an empty shapeless void with light permeating every inch of it, and no hint as to where the light comes from. Heck, where does the oxygen come from? I don't see any plants sitting around.

"Blaarjiim, you know a lot about Wordsmithing, right?"

"Define 'a lot'." Blaarjiim's reply is anything but reassuring. "I know a few things."

"Where did you learn about Wordsmithing?"

"From Yama."

"And where did he learn about it?"

Blaarjiim crosses his arms in my mind's eye. "Yama has many ways of learning information."

"You don't actually know?"

"No."

"Well, if you won't be much help, I'll just figure my limits out myself." I pull the sling holding Blaarjiim off my neck and set it and his orb on the ground. " **Visibility.** "

He pops into existence, and for once his mental self looks interested in what I'm doing. "You're going to figure out your limits?"

"Most assuredly. I may not be a scientist like Marie, but I understand the principle of theorizing and testing until a process is understood fully. Wordsmithing may break several rules of how the universe works, but surely it has its own internal logic."

"I see. Well, I do know one limitation Wordsmithing has... it cannot alter a person's free will."

Blaarjiim's remark makes me furrow my brow. "You can't alter free will? How do you mean?"

"I mean just what I said. If you order a woman to love you with Wordsmithing, she will not. If you order a man to tell you something you want to know, you will fail."

A small chuckle escapes my lips. "Heh, that's stupid."

"I know. For a power so awe-inspiring, having such a pathetic limitation is laughable."

"Oh no, not that." I quickly correct Blaarjiim. "I mean the concept of blocking a person's free will. I could get around that with Wordsmithing's structure as I know it. If I wanted a woman to love me, I could simply alter the chemicals in her brain. If I want the man to tell me the truth, I'll just concoct a truth serum that never fails and he'll have no choice. These are all too easy."

Blaarjiim is clearly taken aback. "Oh. I'm surprised you thought of that so quickly."

"It's basic psychology. Hell, I could use risk/reward and operant conditioning to force someone to love me. Whether it's 'genuine love' or not is largely up for debate. If the end result is merely loyalty or fleshy pursuits, that is all too easy to adjust with Wordsmithing."

I pace away from the orb and stare forward into the never-ending distance before me. "Indeed, I do not believe that Wordsmithing holds any real restrictions I can't get around... aside from the one-word limit, and the amount of energy needed to perform certain feats."

The person in the black orb seems very interested in what I'm doing now. "What do you mean by energy limits?"

"Well, as one example, I can't teleport just anywhere. The further I jump from my current position, the more energy that jump costs. My body is quite limited when it comes to the amount of energy I can hold. Increasing it is a future priority of mine."

"Who says you can?" Blaarjiim beams a smug expression into my mind. "Maybe you're stuck with what you've got."

"No... I doubt that. I can drain energy from others, using the powers that the word 'Drain' gave me. When I stole energy from several golden commandos all at once, for a brief moment I felt it. My energy capacity increased almost imperceptibly, as well as the amount I was currently holding at that moment."

I pause to tap my lips while I stare at his orb thoughtfully. "That was only the second time I felt my energy capacity increase. The first time was when I accepted your power. I later felt an increase for a third time, albeit only a temporary one, when Benjamin doused me with anti-energy and tried to mind-control me in Marie's laboratory. You gave me a huge surge in energy, but it merely overfilled me, and the energy was incompatible with my own so it wore off afterward."

"Uh huh. How did you figure all of this out, anyway?"

His innate distrust can be comical sometimes. "It's just a feeling, but I somehow understand it on a primal level. If I had to describe how my energy works to someone who has never used magic, I would say it's as much a part of me as breathing is. I don't even bother to think about it."

Blaarjiim seems unconvinced. "Whatever works for you, I suppose. I feel like you're angling for something here, but I can't tell what."

I decide not to answer him, and instead opt to *show* instead of *tell*. " **Gravity.** "

Nothing happens. Blaarjiim watches and his head moves around in my mind, as if searching for something different. "What did you do?"

"Nothing. I spoke a word of power and deliberately thought of manipulating the gravity in the room, but also that I wanted the gravity to remain unchanged. It worked splendidly."

"What?! Did you bring me here to waste my time?! That was pointless!" The man blubbers and stammers, clearly annoyed by my antics.

"Do you know what causes gravity?"

My question makes Blaarjiim pause. "I don't know what gravity is."

Oh. I didn't expect that. "Gravity is one of many natural forces in the universe, and possibly the most pervasive. I don't fully understand how it works myself either, especially as I was never one to pay attention in school, but it has something to do with the mass of a large object attracting other objects to it. Distance is also a factor."

Unfortunately, Blaarjiim already seems he's about to tear up out of boredom. "Great... it sounds really fascinating. I'm on the edge of my seat. Can you get on with it already?"

"Sorry. Look around you at this blank canvas I've created. There are no plants, yet I can breathe. This dimensional space is not a planet, yet it has gravity identical to Earth's, my home planet. There is light, but no Sun. Somehow it is perfectly habitable for me, despite the fact it should be a vacuum deathtrap that kills me instantly. Don't you find that odd?"

Blaarjiim suddenly perks up. "Seven devils... you're right! That is very odd. What are you saying, then? Wordsmithing has hidden properties?"

"Something like that. It's not just a matter of speaking words that represent something. If I say 'flower' and a flower sprouts out of the ground, it's not because the word 'flower' is a magical word. My interpretation of the word 'flower' in my mind allows me to create it."

The demon in the orb doesn't say anything for a few moments, but once he does, there's a distinct impression of awe in his voice. "So... you can say any word, and have it take effect as you please?"

"Yes... somewhat. There are human limitations though, mostly that my mind itself is the barrier. It's easier to say 'flower' and imagine a flower, than to say 'dog' and create a flower. There is one other issue, as well, and it is far more sinister. The reason people I clone have no personality at first is because they are created by my knowledge of what they look like. I don't know every minute detail about their original forms, or even about myself for that matter, so only once I order them to be sentient do they start moving around. Danis was very incomplete even after I tried to give him sentience, because I barely knew anything about him. Ben is much closer to his original form as I interacted with him before I killed him."

"I don't follow your last point. If you don't know every tiny detail about Benjamin, how can you ever give him his original memories and personality back?" Blaarjiim's perplexed expression gives me pause.

"Dunno."

And it's true. I don't know everything about Wordsmithing today, but I need to be ready.

" **Energize.** "

I speak the word of power and wait for a few moments. Nothing happens. I wanted to see if I could spend energy to increase my energy reserves, but that doesn't seem to be possible.

Come to think of it, I was just telling Blaarjiim that draining the energy of those commandos increased my magical energy capacity. Perhaps the solution was right there in front of me.

" **Clone.** " Using my mental image of Ben, I create a clone of Ben once again. This one stares ahead, dead-eyed, waiting for my instructions.

Instead of ordering him to do anything, I reach out with my mind and drain his energy, exhausting him in an instant. He flops over like a wet rag, closes his eyes, and falls asleep without releasing any snoring sounds.

However, my energy capacity does not increase. "That was a failure."

Blaarjiim doesn't understand what I just did. "Why did he collapse?"

"I drained his energy, but my limits didn't go up."

I pace back and forth thoughtfully while Blaarjiim merely gazes at me. "I'm surprised he's still alive. Doesn't draining his energy kill him?"

"No." I shake my head instantly. "Draining his spiritual energy just exhausts him. It's like running for ten straight hours without taking a break. He's probably going to be in a coma for a week." I glance at him and curl up my lip. "Well, it would be, if he were going to still be alive in a week. **Disintegrate.** "

His body explodes into a cloud of dust and settles on the ground. Blaarjiim's reaction is swift. "Seven devils! He just exploded into ash! I'm almost horrified!"

"I considered saying 'vanish' but I wasn't sure if that would make him invisible or make him vanish from this plane of existence. I'd prefer the latter but I wouldn't be able to tell the difference. The thought of him staring dead-eyed until he died of hunger is stomach-churning."

"I see your point." Blaarjiim shudders anyway. Funny, I wouldn't expect the literal embodiment of evil to be so saccharine about someone dying. "Still, if he couldn't give you any

energy, why not try many humans at once? If you drained all of the humans in one of those giant buildings on Earth, surely that would give you a big power boost."

His idea has merit. "Perhaps. But to explain more carefully, when I drained a dozen Golden Commandos all at once, it was like adding a brick onto a skyscraper in terms of energy gain. Even if I drained a million humans all at once, I might be lucky to double my energy reserves. And if a million humans collapse into a week-long coma, the investigation may put me at risk. Humanity has already developed a way to neutralize my magic and cripple me. I am not prepared to deal with such an assault right now."

"Then why not drain the angels? Their reserves are far greater." Blaarjiim offers a helpful suggestion once, but a sinister look appears in his eye. "When you drain a human's energy, it will eventually recover, but energy is an angel's lifeblood. Take it from them, and they will die."

"I'll file that under 'maybe'. I don't know how much of a threat angels and gods are, and given they have a non-aggression pact with humanity, it's just as likely that a horde of anti-energy wielding commandos will show up to put an end to me."

Blaarjiim shakes his head. "What amazes me the most is your way of thinking. You don't object to the genocide of angel-kind out of moral reasons, but because it might cause you minor or serious problems. I know demons who care more for their kind than you do for yours."

"Hey now, that isn't fair." I wave my finger chidingly at the orb sitting on the invisible ground. "You don't seem to care about the demons either."

"Oh, well of course not." Blaarjiim wipes his hair back and shrugs. "After all, at no point in the past or now was I ever a demon."

"You're not? I guess I know less about you than I thought."

"I like it that way."

His comment makes the both of us simply stare ahead idly for a moment before I get back to business. "Moving on, I'm thinking that I need to look into other ways I can exploit loopholes in Wordsmithing to my advantage. Only being able to use one word sucks, but if intent matters more than anything else, by mastering control of my mind... I could make things happen that weren't previously possible."

"Such as?"

I start ticking off the examples on my fingers. "Well, I could alter fundamental laws of the universe, change human will, and even bring people back from the dead, for starters."

"You can't bring people back from the dead?"

Blaarjiim asks the question, and my mind blanks out.

"Well... no. I don't believe I can."

I can't? How would I know that? I've never tried to bring anyone back from the dead. I just clone them. Well, now's as good a time as any.

I aim my mind at the pile of ashes I made when I killed Ben. " **Resurrect.** "

"Huh, would you look at that. Guess you can't do it after all."

I nod slowly as I stare at the pile of ash. "Yeah... how about that." Sometimes I have these weird insights into my powers, insights I couldn't have possibly gained unless I had already experimented with my powers. It's so strange.

Blaarjiim suddenly jerks his head up. "I've got it! I know how you could increase your energy reserves!"

His excitement is contagious. "Oh really? How?"

"Just clone yourself! If you do that and you take the energy from the clone, you'll increase your energy dramatically!"

I think about it for a few seconds. "I shouldn't."

"Why not?" The smile on his face, creepy as it is, melts away. "Seems sensible to me."

"Why would I bring another Wordsmith into existence? That's probably how I got here. That other guy cloned himself and it turned into me, and then I defeated him. Cloning myself is a recipe for disaster."

I slowly shake my head as I stare into the distance. "Only an absolute moron would do that."

Part 422b: Broken Home

My eyes open up as the morning dawn peeks through the window, and I unleash a mighty yawn, feeling every muscle in my body crackle as I stretch. Sarah isn't in bed now. She tends to wake up and slip out of bed early a lot lately. It's annoying, if you ask me.

Then again, a man does enjoy some alone time, especially when he's Supreme Commander, leader of the entire human population spread over a hundred star systems. Yup, I lead the biggest galactic group of whiners in the Milky Way. For an entire year, I've been giving my heart and soul to try and improve life for the masses.

Tch. And look what it's given me.

I roll over and slide my legs out of bed, yawning once again. " **Shave.** " My facial hair vanishes. Sometimes I wonder why I don't just make my beard stop growing entirely. It only takes a second to wordsmith the hair away, so I guess it doesn't matter. What does one second mean in the lifetime of an immortal?

I use my telekinesis to hover out of bed, yanking my invisible armor onto myself, along with all my normal clothes I'll need for the day. No need to brush my teeth, thanks to Wordsmithing my mouth is always in perfect condition.

"Oh, you're up." A growly voice murmurs from the opposite side of the room. My dog crawls up off the floor and shakes her tail at me, like the idiot she is. "I'm starving."

"Yeah, I bet you are, Markbark. Always looking for a handout. **Steak.** "

A juicy steak pops out of midair and lands on the ground in front of her. She rolls her eyes. "I hate steak. You know that. Also, are you ever going to call me by my actual name?"

"You hate steak? It must have slipped my mind." I ignore her other question and hide a smile behind my hand as I head to my bedroom door. Already I can feel her scowl on my back as I open the door and step out into the living room.

Timothy is here again. He spots me and smiles. "Hey, dad. How are you this morning?" He's probably working on homework on his datapad, as 'kids' do. I remember when I was shocked to learn that school takes 400 years to complete, but it doesn't seem that long to him.

"I'm good, Tim." My eyes swing across the room to Sarah, sitting at the kitchen counter, tapping through her datapad as well. She doesn't look at me. "Hello, Honey, how are you this morning?" I try to break the tense atmosphere she puts off lately with an icebreaker.

"Fine, thanks." She gives me two words in response. Another one of *those* mornings. I create food for her and Timothy to eat every day, and she slowly treats me like a domestic feline as time goes on, keeping me at arm's length. This is what I get for providing for the family?

No, no, calm down, me. You've meant to do this for weeks. Now is as good of a time as any. "Hey, Sarah, would you mind talking with me in our room real quick?"

Her eyes flick up to meet mine, and she crosses her arms. Great, this looks like positive body language. "Sure."

I catch Tim glancing at both of us as we step in the room, and just before I close the door, he flicks the viewscreen on and turns the volume up. Smart. I'd do the same thing if I were in his shoes too.

"Okay. What is it?" Sarah sits on the bed and stares at me as I close the door. Her gaze could make a second layer of frost spread over ice.

I inhale slowly to keep myself calm. "Look, I just want to know... where we are. Us. You and I. We haven't had sex in weeks. You barely even look at me. Even Tim seems disturbed by this... this rift coming between us. What's going on?"

She rolls her eyes in response. I have yet to see a smile on her face since the divide started growing between us, and it certainly doesn't look like I'll be seeing it today.

"You think I'm stupid, don't you, Jason?"

Her question leaves me grasping at straws. "I... what? No. Why would you say that?"

She crosses her legs, probably just to keep her body language closed, along with her arms. "You think I wouldn't, or *couldn't* put two and two together? Marcus Atkins was the last one to go. I had my suspicions when Jeremy vanished. He was the first one. People don't just die, Jason. Not in this society."

My gut wrenches and a wave of shock hits me. "Are... are you saying I killed them? You think I murdered your other lovers?"

"Oh. You're playing stupid now. Come on, Jason. This last year, you've gotten more and more clingy. You're downright possessive; you know that? You're not you. Of course, I figured it out by the time you killed Sasha. I was too sickened and scared to say anything."

She's serious. She thinks I killed her sexual partners. I mean, truth be told, it had occurred to me, but I wouldn't be so sloppy about it. "Come on, Sarah, let's be serious. I've told you about the Blood Shadow. This guy has knocked off two hundred of our top politicians. Seriously! I've told you about him ten times now! It wasn't me! If it was me trying to be possessive or whatever, don't you think I'd just erase your memory afterward?"

Sarah is taken aback, and she covers her hand with her mouth. "You- you can erase my memory?! You never told me Wordsmithing could do that!"

"That's not really the point, but yeah I could." Her shocked expression makes me flinch inwardly. "Oh, come on! I've never erased your memory! Be realistic!"

"Have you?! How would I even know? With how weird you've been, constantly asking me where I'm going, sending that dark-skinned man to follow me around, what am I supposed to think?"

"You mean Ben? With the Blood Shadow around, I can't take a chance he'll target someone in my family! Come on-" I take a step forward and lower my voice, but she jumps up from the bed.

"Don't come any closer. I don't trust you. I've been thinking, you know. You're different. Very different. It took me a while to notice, but with all the things you keep forgetting here and there, these new mannerisms of yours, and even the way you get confused by basic technology... I think Marie tampered with you. Didn't she? You're not the same man that was my husband two years ago. You're not!"

My tongue snakes out of my mouth as I wet my lips. "For Christ's sake. You're making a big deal about nothing. Seriously, this is a big pain in my ass right now."

"Oh, it's a pain? I'm sorry. I didn't mean to *inconvenience* you." Sarah makes a snappy motion with her hand in front of my face. "If I'm in your way, I'll get out. We're done."

"You're..." I start to say something as she pushes past me. "...breaking up with me?"

"I'm breaking up with you, but not the man I loved before. Whoever you are, you're an imposter. In fact, the more I think about it, the more your actions make sense. All these weird new laws, the murders, everything. This..." She pauses and for once I spot hesitation in her eyes as she looks away. "...this is the hardest thing I've ever done. I loved you, Jason. Really."

I don't even bother to stop her as she pushes the door open and the sound of the news channel floods the room. She doesn't even look at Tim, but grabs a bag I hadn't even noticed inside a closet and walks to the door.

Tim calls after her. "Are you going somewhere, mother?"

I stand in the room and listen as she forces a smile into her voice. "Your father and I are taking a break. I'm going to a friend's place."

"Oh..." Tim's voice trails off, and a moment later I hear the front door slide shut.

Moldgarnish stares at me with the same stupid expression she always has. "Wow, you murdered her other lovers, huh? You're a real dog."

"Shut the fuck up, stupid." I slam the door behind me as I leave my room. The viewscreen is still blaring. " *Supreme Commander Jason Hiro's newest laws are once again met with the 120th consecutive day of protests as people rally together to stand up to his favoritism towards the upper classes. As our reporters on the ground have covered in every broadcast since the story began, the addition of fresh food in the supply chains has been concentrated entirely among the top 1% of citizens, ranging from diplomats to-* "

"Turn that shit off. TV's garbage anyway." I reach out with my telekinesis and send a wave of energy at the screen, shattering it in an instant. Shit! I didn't mean to break the goddamn thing. What are they made of, plastic?

Tim stares at me silently for a few moments. "It's been a long time since I saw you this angry, dad."

"Sorry. It's not you. You're just about the only good thing in this society." I force a weak smile and walk over to him, then rustle his hair around. "It's just hard. Leading all of humanity, and all they do is complain about every law I pass."

With a slow nod, Tim takes a bite of a sandwich to his side. "Is it true what the media is reporting? They say suicides have increased by around ten thousand percent."

I bow my head quickly and turn away. "Thirteen thousand. The media's statistics are old. But yes. Unintended consequences, I suppose."

"Mmm." Tim finishes his bite. "And you diverted food to the upper classes only? Surely they have more than enough."

"Yes. They most certainly do. Ten thousand times too much." I slump down into a chair beside him. "It's all politics. Kickbacks. To get a law passed, Steven and Jim want a favor, then so do Larry and Bob because the first two wouldn't stop bragging about what they wrung out of me. Democracy is the bane of my existence. Monarchy would be a whole lot easier, son."

Tim smiles and pokes me in the rib. "You have that fancy magic, right? Why not just take control and transform the democracy into a monarchy? It's not like you're going to die. Benevolent monarchy has many tangible benefits over democracy, and the worst part of monarchy usually happens when a good king dies, and an evil one takes over."

Smart kid. Too bad he's wrong. "You think these politicians and generals, with their vast military forces, would be willing to submit to such a thing? Even if I killed them all, I don't think I can manage an empire this big by myself."

Tim raises an eyebrow and slowly takes another bite from his sandwich. "If I didn't know any better, I'd say you've thought this through a few times already."

"Psh. Of course I did. For a smart man, especially one with political clout, all options must always be on the table." I run my finger over my smooth face. "Do you think I look better or worse without a beard?"

"Huh? I don't know." Tim chews his food even more slowly, and his eyebrow raises even higher. "Why do you ask?"

"I'm not sure. I just wonder if maybe the lack of beard is another reason your mother-" I stop myself from saying anything else. "Ahh, never mind. In any case, I need to head out. I have a meeting planned with Zachariah Mikhail in a couple of hours. We have to discuss how we're going to shift public relations from red to green. Well, you've seen the news, you know how it is."

There's a feeling of discomfort between us as I stand up and start to walk for the door, but Timothy stops me. "Uh, hey. Should I call a repairman?" He tilts his head toward the viewscreen and gestures toward it guiltily.

"What? You wanna watch cartoons or something? I have to do everything around here." Despite my words, I have to smile. He's such a good kid. " **Repair.** "

The screen magically fixes itself in a single second, and I clean up leftover debris on the ground with one additional incantation. "Alright, Tim, I'm off. Don't work too hard on homework. Invite a girl over, maybe. You're too young to be studying every day."

He taps his lip thoughtfully. "Hmm. I dunno, women seem like a lot of trouble."

"No denying that."

* * *

"Your aura is quite cloudy today. More-so than usual." Blaarjiim's snakelike voice whispers in my mind as I head to the rendezvous point to meet Ben. "Is something distressing you?"

I round a corner past a crowd of angels and humans, all of them headed in one direction or another, and then I get on the hovershaft and start my descent down to the mid-levels. Luckily nobody else is in the hover-box today as I descend, or I might just erase them from the face of the universe.

"Don't play coy, Blaarjiim. You were in the room when it happened."

Indeed, his orb is always suspended invisibly from the ceiling, twenty feet up, where Sarah can't bump into him or find him by accident.

"I was sleeping."

Groan. "Of course you were. Well, you didn't miss much. Melodrama from a woman. I give her the world, and she dumps me. It was like a scene out of a bad romance movie. I hope she doesn't think I'll go and try to win her back. If that's how she's going to be, I couldn't care less about anything involving her. Waste of time, chasing after women."

Blaarjiim nods diplomatically. "Mmm. Yes, indeed. You don't care at all, yet here you are grumbling after she stormed out. Did you kill her other lovers, after all?"

"No. Don't be stupid. I didn't like them, but they were never an obstacle to my plans. Also, now I know you're lying. You saw the whole thing. Even you feel the need to waste my time."

"You're just fun to poke and prod, these days." Blaarjiim's stare takes on a melancholy tone. "You are looking rather haggard though, if I'm being honest. You never really smile, and I haven't seen a spark of wonder in your eyes for a long time."

Oh great. The pitch black Embodiment of All Evil Contained Within a Single Orb is taking pity on me. I'm going to vomit. "Yeah well, this society of pseudo-immortals is sickening. Their concept of time is different from mine. It took half a year to get anything passed through the democratic court system, and all these people do is whine about how rapidly the changes are taking place. They've had six months to get used to everything!"

My foot starts to tap impatiently as the hover-shaft crawls down the side of my megascraper. "Really! It's not my fault that the military sucked up 90% of the energy created by the new Dyson Spheres, or that the rich and powerful take all the food for themselves! I don't even know why the military needs all that energy! What the hell are they doing, shining giant spotlights directly at stars to try and waste the energy as quickly as they can?! It's absurd!!"

Blaarjiim listens calmly to my ranting. "Humans are flawed. Surely now you can appreciate the demon and angel hierarchies? After all, they never question their leader, no matter who he is. Human democracy is a shallow attempt by the mighty to appease the weak. You should be cracking the whip and getting them back to work."

"Yeah. That sounds pretty freaking good right now." I feel as if lately I need a cigarette. I need something, maybe just therapy. "The demons have it made. Speaking of which, I wonder what Yama's up to. Haven't spoken to him at all in the last year."

Blaarjiim is uncharacteristically silent. "I wonder."

"Do you know something?"

My question doesn't get answered. The hover-shaft comes to a stop, and the door slides open, revealing Benjamin Brown's familiar frowning face. "Two minutes early. Punctual as usual."

I fall into step beside him as he sighs and reads from a list of tasks for the day. "Meeting with Mikhail, appointment with the director of public relations, lunch at four thirty- are you listening?"

"Huh? Yeah, definitely." I'm not. My mind is wandering. I just want this day to be over, and the next one, and the one after that... maybe I should just clone myself and have him do all the world while I go relax. I could be having so much fun with my Wordsmithing! I could look up the hottest models of our society, clone them, maybe make them all die in a monster truck rally. Anything would be more exciting than this.

* * *

Forty-five minutes later, we arrive at Mikhail's apartment. For a guy in the upper district, having a side-window apartment facing the sunset is lame. Most other people prefer waking to the sun in their eyes. It's a better way to start the day.

Ben presses the button to ring his doorbell, and we both just stand, waiting. I can't help but vocalize the situation. "Guy doesn't live like a senator in charge of the Mobius cluster, does he? This hallway's kinda cramped."

Ben nods as he rings the bell a second time. "I've spoken to him a few times, though I doubt he'd recognize me. He's a pretty humble, down to earth man. He never flaunts his credits or anything like that. I think he seriously cares about humanity. He's honest."

"Let's hope so. I've had enough of crooks for the day."

A minute passes. I glance uneasily at the door. "Zachariah's sure taking his sweet time."

"Strange. We're right on time. Maybe we should try again later?" Ben's voice has an edge of suspicion to it. "Mikhail's not one to forget appointments."

"Hmm. **Locate.**" I beam my mind indoors, but my location ping comes back negative. "He's not inside, or outside, or anywhere else. He's-" My breath catches. "Holy shit! I think he's dead!"

I don't even bother waiting. With a quick glance to see if anyone's watching, I smash the door inward with my telekinesis. Ben rushes in behind me as I sweep the room. It takes me just seconds to spot him.

"Fucking hell! The Blood Shadow got him! Snapped neck!" Ben runs forward to try and lift him up. "He's still warm! Can you heal him?"

I check his mind for mental activity. "No. He's dead. This kill must be fresh. Watch out, the killer could still be-" A window, still open, catches my eye. "Hey! Isn't there a theory that the Blood Shadow enters and exits through windows to avoid detection?"

"Yeah. Why?" Ben walks over to me and spots what I'm looking at. "Shit. He got away."

"Maybe. I'm going after him."

Ben shoots a look of incredulity at me. "Are you serious? What if you're seen?!"

"I can be stealthy if the need arises. **Cuffs. Invisibility.** "

Metal cuffs appear on my wrists and ankles, though no chains connect them. They, along with the rest of my body and clothing, turn invisible as I rush forward and leap out the window.

Using my telekinesis, I manipulate the cuffs to aim myself like a bullet, straight down. Within seconds I'm moving faster than free-fall speed, all while smoke and smog blast past me at increasing speeds. Luckily I don't feel much of anything thanks to my invisible armor, which makes me nearly as durable as if I had wordsmithed 'Invincibility' on myself.

The windows blur past and I get a horrible scare as even a hover-shaft races upward, missing me by inches and blasting past with a howl that makes my bones shiver. I aim myself a bit further from the side of the building, just in case, and after a few minutes of free-falling, I slow myself to a rapid stop, nearly making myself retch from the sudden G-forces pulling on my body.

As I expected, there's a window open, leading to a room leading lord-only-knows-where. I do, however, spot the catwalks spanning megascrapers and stratoscrapers nearby, meaning this area is right around the mid-level sections of Earth's population.

How curious. I teleport instantly inside the window and land silently on a tiled floor. This room is... a utility closet? Automated bots for cleaning sit at their docking stations, waiting to be activated, and in this tight space with the walls only being five or so feet apart, it's here that I spot... *her*.

Well then. Now I know who the *Blood Shadow* is.

* * *

My heart is still racing! After riding down the utility hover-shaft cabling with Steven's special gadget, I was able to get to the bottom faster than I ever have before... but what a scary descent! If I weren't as strong as I am, the stop would have probably broken my arm.

Broken? Well... what's an arm, I guess. I deserve worse. That politician served the demons, as did all the others, so I snapped their necks. That's what I do now. I'm a killer.

When did it become normal for me to kill? I never wanted to do this. Steven says it's for a good cause, but is it really? Is murder ever justice?

I've been reading up on old documents. They discuss things like 'court systems' and even 'tribunals', and they all share a common theme; judgement by a group of people. Not one person, but many, representing a collective.

Those don't exist in this time. Here, computers will jail a person for committing crimes, but computers can only distinguish between black and white. They can tell if a man stabs and kills a woman, or if someone steals property, but what about something like high treason? If someone is collaborating with demons, will a computer know that?

Unlikely. And it isn't against the law anyway! These people fraternizing with the enemy are a bigger danger to society than the murderer and the thief, but they won't ever be punished!

So, if that's the case, then it's okay for me to kill them, right? I mean... they become angels anyway. They don't die forever. It's not as bad that way.

In some cases, it can even be a good-

Thud.

A sound to my side. The sound of something landing lightly on the floor, but there's nothing visible. Did a robot on the wall shift and I missed it? No! It's... it's something else.

"Lora. I guess it was you all along. **Visible.** "

I can barely contain my excitement, roiling stomach, and horror as a familiar figure appears in front of me. Appearing by magic, Master pops out of the ether to face me. Was he always this tall?! He's a head and a half higher than me, and his presence is intimidating. Before I know it, my fingers start trembling.

"M-Master? I haven't seen you in-"

He interrupts me. "You can speak? Since when?"

I didn't expect him to interrupt me. I need to get some things off my chest. "Well, ah, since I... um... broke out of prison..."

He wipes at his forehead and crosses his arms. "Right. Prison. For killing Danis. Which, by the way, if you had stayed inside, you would have been exonerated of all charges. I managed to convince the authorities that you had found out Danis was a cloned spy working for the demons, and you killed him to protect me. Unfortunately, you murdered a *hundred fucking guards* during your escape, along with the Warden, so now you're a criminal of the most dangerous kind... according to the police forces."

His words make me lower my head in shame. "I... I'm sorry. I didn't know- they were torturing me in prison."

"Come again? Torturing you? How so?"

His words have an edge of curiosity to them, so I spend several minutes explaining what happened and how I got out of prison, though I do skip over who helped me. If Master picks up that I'm leaving someone out, he doesn't mention it.

"I understand now. This explains a lot. I'm..." He pauses for a moment and looks away. "...sorry you had to go through that. Still, you've been killing a lot of people, Lora. Don't pretend this was self-defense. What's your reasoning?"

He looks back and gazes at me, straight in the eye. I suddenly feel uncomfortable.

"I'm killing people who work with the demons. Collaborators."

It takes a second for him to register what I said. "Oh? You're killing people who collaborate with demons, huh? And how do you know these people are what you think they are?"

Crap. I have to tell him about Steven. Not good. Steven will be angry if I tell Master! But then, should I care if he's mad? Steven is Steven... but Master is Master! They aren't the same.

Still... I can't tell Master everything. Not until I know where I stand with him.

I lean back against the metal door, realizing there's no escaping Master's wrath if he gets angry. I can't hope to beat him. "I work for a man. He keeps track of those who go into the Labyrinth to see Yama."

Master smiles and nods nonchalantly. "Ah, so he's the mastermind, huh? Lora... who are you loyal to, again? Is it me, or this other man?"

His question catches me off-guard. I wasn't expecting it. "Uh... you, Master?"

"You don't sound very sure. Let me remind you, Lora, that I was the one who took you from the demons. I gave you the power to fight and live on your terms. Not this other man. I allowed you to kill your tormentor, Danis, and I didn't even punish you. So, Lora, I ask you this... why are you hiding any information from me and protecting this other man instead?"

I don't have a proper answer for his question. "I'm not hiding anything, not really anyway."

Master nods his head slowly. "So you were planning to tell me that Steven Feldmann is the one conspiring against me at some point, then? My own 'son', at that. I should have known."

He knows? But how?! Has he known all along? But he's not the sort of person to just ignore that...

He speaks again. "I can read minds, Lora. I read your thoughts while you debated over whether or not to tell me. It's clear your loyalties have changed over the last year, though why...

I can't say. I'm disappointed though. You're only the second woman today to cast me to the side, after everything I've given you. I'm starting to wonder if there's any point to what I'm doing."

"Wait! It's not like that, Mas-" I have to catch myself. I can't keep calling him that. It's not right. "Jason. I haven't stopped thinking about you, not once over the last year. Don't do this."

"Don't do what? I'm not going to do anything. Go back to Feldmann, tell him whatever you want. Of course, the next time I see him, I'll tear his head off myself, so he'd better stay out of my way. Out of respect for you, I won't kill you."

Jason stares at me silently, and for once I realize something. I've always looked up to him, but I see it now. He's not an immortal demi god or someone I could never hope to reach. He's just a man. A man trying to do what he thinks is the right thing.

And I am the same. I'm a woman, trying to do what I think is right.

"Thank you... Jason. I'm glad I got to see you again."

"Of course you are." He shakes his head and turns back to the sealed window leading outside. "What even is the point anymore, I wonder?"

I don't get a chance to ask what he means. He vanishes instantly, leaving me alone in the closet.

I don't know why... but for some reason, I want to cry and never stop.

Part 423b: The Calm

I keep rubbing my arms, trying to wake them up, but no matter what I do the cold won't go away. I'm in my regular clothes now, the same jumpsuit every other person on Earth wears, yet I feel so distant from them. They aren't like me. They walk down these white halls, staring at devices in their hands, only occasionally glancing up to make sure they don't bump into things.

I can't call him Master anymore. He's just Jason, now. Only now that I've finally spoken to him do I realize how much I miss him. He's cruel, heartless, and emotionally distant in many ways. Somehow, I feel that it's all an act. I remember when a wound from training was causing me a lot of pain. He told me to just grit my teeth and bear it, but only a minute later he couldn't stand to hear me crying, so he healed the wound. He told me at the time that it was just because I was irritating him, but was that the only reason?

I step into the hovercar and press a button, sending it flying back to Feldmann's headquarters. His small organization had no name and went previously unknown to Jason... until I revealed it by accident. Feldmann needs to know. If I can't be by Jason's side, then perhaps I should just keep doing as Feldmann instructs. I'm getting rid of demon sympathizers, after all.

What kind of monster does what the demons ask? They're pure evil. Anyone beholden to a demon is the worst of the worst, a betrayer of their own people.

At least, that's what Steven says.

Jason's words come back to me. *And how do you know these people are what you think they are?*

Were the people I killed demon collaborators? Steven told me they were. He's honest. Amy says he's honest. Is he, though? Has he ever lied to me? What about all the times he said he'd help me speak to Jason to clear my name, but the plans fell through? Were those lies, or just accidents? He is a busy man, after all.

Steven hates the demons. He isn't lying about that much, I know for sure! My people, the Goldeshians, were enslaved by Danis and given to the demons. I was born in that hell, and Steven hated Danis for what he did. Compared with Jason, who spoke on friendly terms with Yama and the others...

Wait. Is that it, then? Is that what I've been missing, all this time? Maybe it's not Steven who is lying, but Jason. Why would he be so friendly with Yama in the first place? Why have all these

new laws he passed come back to hurt humans? Is he actually working with the demons after all?

The Jason I knew, when we met in the Labyrinth, was one who assured me had no interest in doing as Yama asked. He thought of Yama as beneath him. Yama was only a small threat. Jason even joked about ruling the demons if he was going to do anything they wanted him to do.

As my ship lands in Steven's hangar and I get off to head inside, my mind reels from the possibilities.

If Jason is trying to destroy human society, his actions certainly seem the right path to take. Protests, riots, all the chaos I'd expect a destroyer to bring. But if he's trying to destroy it, does that make him wrong?

My footsteps echo off the dingy walls, a sound I've become all too familiar with. The poorly maintained tiled floors have chips and breaks all over, hairline cracks that splinter some of the tiles in half, and stains nobody has ever bothered to clean. We are the resistance, those who fight against the villains threatening to overwhelm human society... but that doesn't mean we're in the right.

Feldmann claims morality is black and white. Demons are wicked, humans are virtuous. I should agree with him, and usually do, but I'm having hesitations. If Jason is the one I've cared most about all this time, and if he supports the demons, where does that leave me? I'm a murderer, after all. Two hundred and five people... that's how many I've killed by Steven's orders. That doesn't even count the people I eliminated before I met him. I can't pretend Jason is evil and I'm good and virtuous... even if I'm murdering evildoers.

My head hurts. I don't know what to do. Maybe thinking about what I 'should' do is wrong. I need to do what I want. I can't keep letting other people dictate my life for me. I can't keep lying to myself... or to others.

I push open the door at the end of the hall, forcing a smile as I spot Steven to the right. He's playing a violin along with the band in the bar. The soft melody contrasts with the 'jazz' sound that the other musicians usually put out. They have to slow down and speed up to match him because the violin stands out so much from the other instruments.

I sit down at a table and wait for a few minutes, watching him silently. Steven always closes his eyes when he plays. He says it's so he can feel the emotion more intensely when the bow crosses over the strings, but I wonder if it isn't because the music takes him to a different place; a world where he doesn't have the responsibilities he does here.

Freedom sounds fantastic... but it's a pipe dream, in the end.

Finally, the song winds down and Steven opens his eyes. Everyone in the room claps and smiles as he steps down, setting his violin to the side, and walks over to his usual private booth. It's not often the leader of the resistance will go out of his way to play music, especially when he's so talented.

Steven spots me as he walks past, and nods toward his booth wordlessly. I quickly get up to follow him, and a few seconds later we sit down beside each other. The bartender gets us our drinks, and Steven decides to mix it up by having some brandy. As for me, I have the usual; a big mug of vodka. I can't help it. The harder the drink, the more easily I can force the guilt down into my stomach.

"Took you longer than usual. Zachariah must have put up a real fight." Steven's still clasping the violin's bow in his left hand, and he rubs his index finger up and down the bowstring as he talks while using his other hand to chug his alcohol.

"Um, no, not exactly. Zachariah wasn't a problem. He... went down easily. Just like all the others."

Steven laughs. "Haha! Yeah, no kidding. I remember that time you accidentally crushed a barbell, then hurled it through a wall in a fit of rage. You're a super-human, that much is for sure." I pull my eyes away from his, and his voice takes on a curious tone. "I guess it's good everything went well otherwise though, right, Lora?"

"Well, I mean, the kill was smooth as always. It's... it's what happened after the kill... that's where things went differently."

Shit. I shouldn't be saying this, but I have to. Steven is in danger, and Jason isn't a forgiving man. If I don't warn Steven, everything we've worked so hard on will fall apart.

"Go on." He prods me gently, but there's some suspicion in his voice. "You don't usually act so reserved."

"I ran into Jason." I spit the words out quickly, and Steven visibly stiffens in response. "He caught me red-handed. We talked for a few minutes... then he let me go."

I glance up at Steven's face to see a mixture of shock and curiosity. "He didn't have you arrested? That's surprising. You must have fed him an excellent line."

"No, Steven. I didn't. He knows everything now. He knows I'm the Blood Shadow, and he knows you're the one giving me orders."

The shock becomes more palpable on Steven's face as he slaps the violin bow on the counter. "You *told him*?! What the hell were you thinking?"

"I didn't tell him. Steven, I haven't been entirely honest with you. There's... there's something you need to know about Jason Hiro. He's not the man you think he is. He's not your father."

A cockeyed smirk spreads across his lips. "Oh, is that so? Then who is he?"

"I don't know, exactly. But the man you call your father, he was defeated in battle by the Jason you see now. This Jason met me in the Labyrinth, trained me, and enhanced me with his powers. When I killed Danis the first time, he cloned Danis using magic."

Steven blinks slowly and mops at his forehead. "You didn't tell me this before? Why not?"

"I don't know. I wasn't sure of what to do. But now that Jason has realized you're the one causing him trouble, he wanted you to know that the next time he sees you, he'll rip your head off. His words, not mine. It's not too late to stop what we're doing."

Steven surprises me by calmly pulling his mug up to his lips and taking a long, slow chug of his brandy. When he's finished, he sets it back down gently and begins to chuckle. "Uh... huhuhu.... by Saint Joseph's name... huhuhu..." His entire body trembles as he suppresses a laugh deep in his gut. "Now it all makes sense. Everything. The pieces connect perfectly."

I nod along uncomfortably. "Yes. He's a different Jason. That's why comparing him to your father's actions makes no sense. They're entirely different people."

"Huh? No, not that. Don't you see, Lora? The reason you said he was so chummy with the demons... his ability to use magic -assuming he actually can, and it wasn't sleight of hand-, and his actions that are clearly harming humanity. When you add it all up, it comes together in one perfect package."

He pauses, as if for dramatic effect. "This fake Jason isn't a human. He's a demon in disguise."

I blink twice to comprehend what he just said. "Th-that's not right at all! He's human! Why would you even think that?"

Steven shakes his head. "You're still not familiar with the intricacies of the four sentient species, Lora. The Volgrim have psionic abilities, given to them by their technology. Angels have magical powers, but those powers come at the expense of their life force. The demons have their own magic, and it can manifest in many ways. Humans, on the other hand, have zero magical aptitude. It's not possible for a human to have magic. Period."

"But- Jason hates the demons! He always treated Yama, the Second Demon Emperor, disrespectfully! I lived among the demons, Steven. No demon can treat a superior contemptuously."

Steven shakes his head again, and his tongue flicks out to wet his lips. "Under ordinary circumstances, I'd say yes. But now it's obvious! This was a long term plan. Yama's goal is to subvert human rule by putting demon-bribed humans in key places, but the highest office's always remained out of his grasp. By replacing my father with a hand-picked shapeshifter, he's been able to do permanent damage to our species. We're weakened now, and the situation's only getting worse all the time."

Steven suddenly spins in his chair and stands up. "This is what I've been needing. You should have told me sooner, but now I have finally gotten to the root of the problem. Thank you, Lora."

I grab his hand. "Hold on, Steven. What are you planning to do? You can't just be brash."

He pulls away from me and takes a step out into the open. "I'm going to test him. If he's really my father, I'll be at ease. But if he's a demon, he won't be able to hide it."

"Steven! Stop!" My voice is louder now, and a few people nearby take notice, but I don't care. "What about the day your father went into the labyrinth? Don't you think that's a bit strange? You've always made him seem like someone who wouldn't do that!"

"Yes. You're right. I don't know why my father would go into the labyrinth without any guards. Perhaps the demons mind-controlled him. He never was much of a fighter anyway. Maybe he thought he could parley with the demons, get them to stop taking slaves. The point is... I don't know! I don't know why he did what he did!" Steven is hissing at the sides of his mouth as he glares at me. "All I know is what you've told me, and what you said confirmed what I've been thinking for a while now. He's a false demon imposter, and I won't let him get away with his crimes."

With a flourish, Steven spins away and walks to the door.

"Steven, wait! Don't do this! Think more carefully!" I yell after him, but he ignores me. Everyone in the room goes silent as he slams the door.

A girl at the closest table gives me a strange look. "What was that for? And what's all this about his father?"

"It's not your business." I quickly get up and chase after him. Whatever he's planning, it sounds dangerous. Jason is going to kill him!

* * *

Ben grimaces as we ride the hover-shaft up to my office. "You really had me worried, you know. I thought we'd have to peel you off the side of a hover-shaft, just like this one. Could you be any hastier if you tried?"

"Probably. Does it matter? I have godlike powers. I'll just be reborn as an angel if I die anyway. The threat was minimal."

"I'm SO glad you're an optimist." He shuffles his feet around before walking to the other side of the shaft to stare at me. "Anyway, what happened? Did you manage to catch the Blood Shadow?"

"Yup. The assassin is a familiar face. Lora."

"The Goldeshian girl?" Ben looks confused. " *Lora* is the professional assassin who's been making mincemeat of politicians and governors all over the system? Of all the people it could possibly be..."

"When you think about it, it fits perfectly into place. There hasn't been another killer among humanity for several thousand years, possibly even millions. I just assumed it was a demon since the murders were executed perfectly every time. In retrospect, the snapped necks should have given it away."

Ben eyes me curiously. "You seem rather calm for someone who just found out that you were betrayed by the very person you trained."

"Betrayed? Yes, I suppose that's an apt description. She killed some people who voted yes on my laws, but she also killed others who voted no. I didn't really know any of them well enough to care about their deaths, so beyond their past and future utility to me, they didn't matter."

Ben swallows. "That's a very inhuman way to look at their lives. Don't you care even a little-" He pauses. "Ah, never mind. I know you better than that."

"Yeah, you do. Anyway, it doesn't matter. Now that I'm aware of who's been the pain in my ass for this last year, I'll take care of him soon. Steven Feldmann's days are numbered. I can't just kill him since he's my son as far as the galaxy knows, and ranked rather high on the leadership totem pole. I'll need to be more subtle about it."

"No kidding. Not to mention that with all the people he's had Lora murder, we have too many vacancies in leadership positions across our core sectors. The Liarus system is in dire straits, for example, and Sirius isn't doing too well either."

"I believe it. I've been debating allowing those who were murdered to return to their duties as angels, in fact. That would solve the manpower shortage."

Benjamin stiffens visibly at my suggestion. "Whoa, whoa! Absolutely not! Just letting some angels return to work in the middle levels is bad enough! We absolutely cannot compromise the upper levels and the heart of government!"

"Right, right. I know you hate angels or whatever, but calm down. Ben, these angels were human as recently as a day ago. Do you honestly think they've been compromised so quickly?"

Ben shakes his head. "It's not that. We don't even know the full extent that angels are manipulated by Zeus and the archangels. If Zeus can give out energy to angels to keep them alive, it stands to reason that he can exert pressure by threatening to cut them off if they don't do as he says and spy on us. It's simply not worth the risk. I'd even prefer you just clone them like you did me."

Oh. That's a pretty good idea. I hadn't even thought of it until just now, but since he mentions it...

The Hover-shaft slows as we reach the top. Once it stops and the door opens, we hustle our way down to my office.

"I'll have to think about it, Ben. It takes quite a lot of energy to clone people, and I'm not sure I want to weaken myself like that just yet."

So few people I can trust. Ben *might* be one, since he's a clone I made. Then again, I have no reason to believe that cloned beings are at all safe to treat lightly.

A minute later, we round the corner to my office and- oh. I'm hardly even surprised to see the archangel, Gabriel, standing there waiting for me.

"Supreme Commander, Jason Hiro. I'm sorry to bug you. I've been waiting a while."

I groan inwardly, but force a smile. "Gabriel, no need to feel anxious. I'm always here for a *friend*. What can I help you with?" I let the 'friend' hiss out of my mouth, but the archangel doesn't appear to pick up on it.

"Oh, well, it's regarding the energy supply. Zeus has noted that total energy output over the last year continues to drop steadily every month. We suspect that it's because-

I raise a hand to cut him off. "I already know the reason. On top of the suicide rates of people who see how great it is to be an angel, there are also the people who only stop praying because they think exactly the opposite; that it's awful being an angel. We're working on counter-measures."

Ben pipes up. "Ah, but how are the Volgrim holding up as a backup? We understand that asking for their help might not be ideal, but we hope they are a decent alternative."

Gabriel waves his hand through the air. "Oh, the Volgrim are excellent. Their numbers are far smaller than that held by humanity, but the amount of spiritual energy is much greater. Quality, not quantity, I suppose you could say."

"I suppose so." I gesture to my office. "Let's go and discuss this inside. I needed to use my office computer to do some work, anyway."

Gabriel offers no protest, and we head inside. As we walk, I glance over at the desk where my dutiful new assistant is working hard. Unlike that worthless girl, Stephanie, this man is punctual, polite, and always works hard.

"Keep up the good work, Silver."

He looks up at me and smiles. "Yes, sir! Glad to be of service!"

What a hard worker. I wish everyone could be as talented.

* * *

Two figures stand atop a skyscraper, staring up at the buildings that dwarf theirs, stretching for miles up into the sky. The air, bitter and acrid, swirls around them, but the woman's body projects an invisible field around herself and her companion, to protect them. Her beautiful white armor glistens, even in spite of the dim sunlight that barely pieces the smog in all directions. She rests her hand on the majestic sword at her waist and sighs.

"Grok, are we certain this is the right stream? I feel as though we are in the second layer of Hell, one that extends into a realm we should never see. To imagine this is the stream where everyone will converge; it's absurd."

The massive green orc beside her nods. "This is the only one left, Daisy. We've checked the others, front to back. Based on my notes, we're close. We can finally stop the chaos. We can unravel the threads of fate that bind all realities together. There's just one mystery left to solve."

Daisy swallows, despite the lump in her throat. "We have to find the arbiter of the multiverse's destruction, and stop him ourselves. The Wordsmith is not yet ready for the task."

Grok rubs his hand on the reddish orb atop his staff. "We don't know that yet. In fact, we might be the ones to destroy the multiverse. Never presume unless you have all the necessary information, my dear."

"Sorry. I'm just rash, I guess." Daisy grips the sword's hilt tighter. "I just pray I don't have to kill Jason. If push comes to shove, I'll do whatever it takes."

"That's a good attitude. Come on, let's go." Grok rubs her shoulder, and a moment later, both of them vanish. The winds swirl together to envelop the place where they stood just moments earlier.

Part 424b: Usurper

Having an archangel visit me in my office slowed down my plans for the day, especially given he practically ambushed me, but it had to be done. Finally, I've finished our discussion, and we're ready to go.

I step out of my chair and grumble under my breath. "Well, in any case, I believe that I've come up with satisfactory appeasements for your concerns, Archangel Gabriel? I obviously don't want your people dying off due to lack of energy."

Gabriel nods slowly, but a guilty look passes over his face. "You know, I pushed Zeus to open up the gates of Heaven. I agreed with what you wanted to do, so I told the King that it would be best to give it a shot. I didn't realize that it would have so many disastrous consequences."

Ben coughs into his fist. "Yeah, I disagreed from the beginning, but I figured it would take things going wrong for everyone to see the errors in their ways. Whatever, I suppose."

"What's done is done. I'll look into limiting travel once again. I do want it to be more open than it used to be, but there's clearly a middle ground I can aim for." I walk over to the door and beckon, so Gabriel and Ben both get up to follow me. "In any case, mistakes were made. I'm sorry for the trouble I've caused the gods and angels."

Gabriel scratches his head sheepishly as his wings tuck in closer to his body. "It's no trouble at all. Let's just both agree there was blame on both sides and call it a day, hmm?"

"That sounds fair."

The door hisses open, and the three of us step into the hallway, but a blur of motion catches my eye. Pivoting on his heel to face me is the angry face of a familiar man.

"Supreme Commander, Jason Hiro. I would call you 'father', but it seems that word is not applicable anymore."

Steven Feldmann stands just ten feet away, along with two guards to either side of his body, all four of them wearing the Hypersuits I've seen in action so many times over this last year. Given the cuffs hanging from their waists, and the guns slung across their backs, they mean business.

Gabriel takes a step forward to look at me inquisitively. "Mister Hiro, what is the meaning of this?"

Shit. The little punk came looking for me? I didn't expect this. Still, what does he think he can accomplish? He's well below me in political rank... and clout.

I ignore Gabriel's question. "Steven, I don't know what's going on here, but you're not thinking clearly."

"I'm quite sure of what I'm doing. You're a fake. An imposter! You are a demon, shapeshifted to look like a human. Gabriel, you should stand away from him. The Supreme Commander is not human."

Indeed, Gabriel takes a step to the side. "I have not sensed any demonic energy from this one. Perhaps your father is right, Mister Feldmann. I've known you a long time, and you're acting out of character."

"The hell I am!" Steven raises his blaster and aims it right at my chest. "This is an anti-energy rifle. It does not affect an ordinary human, but against a demon, it will incinerate you! This is the perfect test to prove I'm right."

The guards to his side take a step forward in alarm. "Steven Feldmann, this is wrong. By raising your weapon against the Supreme Commander, you're committing treas-"

"Shut up!" Steven's eyes open even wider, and his hand shakes slightly as he aims the blaster at me. "A demon is destroying humanity! Look at what he's done already, in just one short year!"

Anti-energy. Goddammit. If I had known he was out here, I could have expelled the energy from my body and that blaster wouldn't affect me, but in front of all these people, and with Gabriel watching... my options are limited.

Blaarjiim speaks quietly into my mind. *Don't worry. I have a plan. When he fires, I will flood your body with my energy, and it will neutralize the anti-energy. It will seem as though you were unharmed.*

I reply telepathically. *I guess that might be worth trying. I don't have a better idea right now. I don't know if adding a bunch of evil energy to my body will solve the problem or not, though.*

The black orb scoffs. *I'm not evil, human, I am merely one with the darkness. In any case, my energy is very different from that of a demon's. Anti-energy, as you've seen before, ignores it.*

I could try to dodge the attack instead, but won't that look just as suspicious? Damn, that stupid 'son' of mine picked a lousy time to try and kill me.

Fine. We'll do it your way. I hope this works.

I groan dramatically and roll my eyes. "Alright, son. If that's what it takes, shoot me. I have nothing to hide."

When my eyes meet Steven's, there's a moment of hesitation visible as he suddenly doesn't know what to do. It passes momentarily. "What are you trying to pull?! You think I won't shoot? I will!"

"Do it. And the head of the archangels will even be here to bear witness to my innocence. But... if you pull that trigger, you're going to prison for the rest of your immortal life. I urge you to think twice before committing treason."

Confusion is in the air. The guards look at me and then at Steven, as does Gabriel, Silver, and even Ben. I can almost hear Ben in the back of my mind. *Idiot! If he shoots you, you'll die! The more energy you have, the more damage anti-energy does!*

I know that much. However, there is another option.

As Steven sweats, trying to figure out what to do, I hatch an even better plan. I'm not like the Jason before me. I'm smarter, faster, and more adept than he ever was. Wordsmithing is a nearly omnipotent skill, but one has to know how to use it properly for it to reach its peak.

Blaarjiim, I'm going to release my energy, but continue to flood me with yours if things look dire.

He doesn't question me, but his gaze betrays curiosity as he appears in my mind's eye.

"Steven, I'm not trying to trick you. You're my son, and I care about you. However, if you go down this path, I will have no choice but to **expel** you."

As the words leave my lips, I turn one of them into a word of power, changing its definition in my mind to something akin to 'release my energy'. I feel my shoulders sag as the power leaves me.

Just in the nick of time, too. My final speech rouses Steven, and his finger hovers over the 'fire' button. "Now I know you're a liar. My father never cared about me, not a day in my life."

"You're wrong." The words slip from my mouth, and for once, I'm not even lying.

Foom!

Steven fires the blaster, and the blast impacts me square in the chest. There's a stinging pain in my lungs for just a half second, enough for me to clutch my chest, but Blaarjiim extinguishes the pain a second later.

I quickly inhale and shake my head slowly at Steven.

"Sir! Are you okay?" Silver jumps over his desk and runs to me, but I stop him.

"I'm fine. It just managed to startle me, that's all. I didn't think my son would shoot me."

Steven's eye twitches and he gnashes his teeth. "Y-you liar! You were in pain! I saw it! That blast hurt a lot, didn't it?!"

He starts to tap the fire button again, but two of the guards jump him and pin him to the floor. Gabriel exhales while Steven tries to wrestle free on the ground. "What a relief. He was so sincere that he almost had me worried for a moment."

"Yeah. Heh. He even had me doubting myself." I let a nervous chuckle out, even as Steven glares fireballs at me.

"You're a fake! I know it! What did you do to my father?! You piece of fucking shit! Murderer! I oughta-!" A guard wraps a gag over his mouth and pulls him up, holding him firmly so he can't wriggle free.

"We're very, very sorry about this, Supreme Commander. He didn't tell us why we needed to accompany him. We'd have warned you otherwise."

The guard looks like he's terrified I'm going to fire him for insubordination on the spot. Honestly, I want to, but it all worked out in the end.

"Don't worry about it. Take my son away, but treat him gently. He's just misguided." I make sure to show leniency in front of Gabriel. I can always break Steven later when nobody is watching.

The guards nod, and a few moments later they've rounded the far hallway, all while dragging my son as he tries to scream profanities through his gag.

Silver walks back over to sit at his desk, and I sigh. "I don't know what got into him. I'm sorry, Archangel Gabriel. This must have been pretty distressing for you."

He nods along, but there's something in his eyes that makes me wonder what he's thinking. "It was fairly alarming, but also exciting at the same time. Well, the thing is though, when the anti-energy struck you... you did clutch your chest. What was that about?"

"It's a flinch reaction," Ben interjects. "When I was in the military forces, they would take us out and fire anti-energy at the recruits, just to show them how to tell demons apart from humans. Most people flinch the first few times they're shot at, but it fades once you're used to it."

"Ah. I see." Gabriel scratches his chin. "Well, there was something else, but... ah, whatever. In any case, I need to be heading back to tell Zeus about your verdict regarding Heaven's migration policies. He will be quite happy to hear about your change of opinion, given how catastrophically everything has turned out."

Ben waves a finger in the air. "It hasn't all been bad. People have still been able to see their loved ones, after all. At the least, we achieved that much."

"You are correct." Gabriel bows at the neck, and once we return the gesture, he gracefully walks away, leaving Benjamin and I to our own devices.

Once he's out of range, Ben and I head back into my office. Only once the sound-proof door seals shut can I finally let off some steam.

"GODDAMN IT! THAT STUPID, WORTHLESS-"

I have to stop myself from saying anything else, but I release several long deep breaths. "We are fortunate that worked out so well. I've never been as angry and disappointed as I am now."

Ben fans his face, in spite of the fact the room is quite cool. "How did Steven find out? And how did that anti-energy not tear you apart? Concentrated anti-energy fired from a blaster is not the same as the anti-energy a room like this can create. It will liquefy a demon if they have enough energy concentrated inside themselves."

I decide to tell him a half truth. "I released the energy from within myself once I saw that Steven had the blaster. Luckily, nobody noticed when I did it."

"No joke. Angels are very good at detecting energy types, you know." Ben wipes his forehead. "If he'd sensed you were expelling that energy, you'd be in deep shit. Short of killing and cloning him, you'd have no way to stop him from turning angel-kind against us."

"It's in the past now. What isn't in the past, however, is Lora. She betrayed me deliberately and told Steven I was a fake. I have to assume anyone working with Steven is going to know as well. After everything I did for her, she showed her true colors, in the end. I should have known better than to give her mercy."

Ben walks over and leans against my window heavily. "Don't let it get to you. You avoided the worst of it. Things can't get worse; they can only get better now that you've cast aside the conspiracy about yourself."

"Don't say that, Ben. Every time someone says 'things can't get any worse', the universe seeks to find irony in that moment."

"Maybe not this time?" Ben's voice has more hope in it than I'd like to hear right now.

"Don't press our luck."

* * *

It takes nearly a full day of traveling, but thanks to my personal transport ship, supplied by the humans, I arrive back at the familiar sight of Heaven's Gate. A tremendous circular warp-

hole where I can see my home dimension on the other side, it stands out from all the other buildings in the area. While I've never been to the one that leads inside the demon's realm, I'm told that it's identical to Heaven's Gate.

What does that say about humans, I wonder? They constructed two great warp-gates, one that leads to the lair of their greatest enemy, and the other which allows them to visit their closest allies... but they made the structures identical. Does that mean humans think of angels and demons in the same way? Are we monsters, just the same as the demons, but with a different outer shell?

It's an amusing thought. The great irony is that if their views were such, our views toward them are the same as well. Humans and demons seem closer than one might think, especially after giving them more than a passing glance. Humans enslave, torture, murder, and do all the things they worry demons will do to them.

Perhaps that is why they fear the demons. Not because the demons are ugly, or powerful, or anything like that, but because the demons are a stark reminder of the typical human's weakness.

Once my ship has landed, I step off and fly over to Heaven's Gate. I need no identification, so commanding is my presence. Several people bow visibly once they see me, before returning to their work. Even if their jobs keep them near Heaven, before the Supreme Commander's loosening of the travel restrictions, few humans had ever seen an angel, let alone a pure-blood, and especially not an Archangel. There are only three of us left, after all. Raphael, Uzziel, and myself.

My sandals scuff the cement lightly as I approach Heaven's Gate. The ring on my finger feels unusually heavy today, though I don't know why. I can only occasionally have a conversation with Michael, but he always seems foggy... distant, even. Was he always like that? So much time has passed since my brother sacrificed himself for the good of humanity, leaving his closest friends behind. The only thing that makes my heart ache more is the realization that Uzziel and Raphael will likely never be able to speak with him. Only I have built the spiritual connection, and when last we tried it was a failure.

"Archangel Gabriel, I see you're back from the human realm." A familiar sappy-faced pureblood stands just before Heaven's Gate and smiles at me. "I came as soon as I heard you were going to arrive. Were you successful with your negotiations?"

"Cherubim Zarall, I hope you are well." I nod slightly at him, just hinting at a bow. "As expected, I was successful. The human's Supreme Commander is unhappy with the current state of things, just as we are. Twisting his arm proved unnecessary."

The Cherub saunters over to me, his long white hair stretching almost down to his heels, and covering most of his body in the process. His face, perfectly shaved as always, shows far more skin than the rest of him would. Of course, being a pureblood, I've known him just as long as all of the palace angels, I just don't venture out to Heaven's Gate very often. Sometimes, seeing someone for the first time in ages can feel like meeting them all over again.

Zarall chuckles. "Sounds like another boring day among the humans, eh?"

We walk through the gate, and I breathe a sigh of relief as I finally stand in the bright, cheerful place I call home. The human-built towers that spiral up into the sky may dwarf the ancient temples we purebloods live in, but they are uniform and ugly compared to the carefully carved perfection of the old structures, built during a time when the utmost care was taken to make them functional... as well as beautiful.

"I wouldn't say it was boring. In fact, something happened, just before I left the commander. He was-" I stop and pause for a moment. "Well, actually, this information is a bit above your position."

"It's no concern of mine if you can't tell me." Zarall weaves his hand inside his hair to scratch his chest. "I'm perfectly content being a nobody who guards the Gate."

"Oh come on, Zarall. You're not a nobody! You're free to visit the temple anytime you want and have another angel take over guard duty."

Sometimes I feel bad for him. The other angels treat him fine, but with all that hair of his, I wonder if it doesn't make others see him as weird. Certainly not me, I couldn't care less.

I relent after he looks away uneasily. "Well, actually, regarding the Supreme Commander... it seems his son made a ploy to grab for power. The pretenses were blatantly false, but he might have gotten away with it if I weren't there to witness it."

Zarall nods sagely, quickly getting back into the mood. "Ah, so you were able to stop him, then?"

"Not in so many words, but my presence was undoubtedly a comfort to Commander Hiro, knowing that I saw the treachery of his son with my own eyes."

We arrive at the Temple of Artemis, and Zarall pauses just outside the great doors. "It sounds like a very exciting time you had, Gabriel, but it's not really for me. I'll go back to checking the scrolls and updating the registry."

"Very well. Take care, friend." I embrace him with a hug, something only one pureblood will ever do with another. There aren't many of us left, after all.

A few minutes later, I stand before the Altar of Saints, a sacred reminder of those who gave up their lives fighting the demons, eons upon eons ago. I like to come here after visiting the humans, and especially before delivering important news to the King. Michael's spirit might be worn upon my finger, but the memory of his self-sacrifice is inscribed here on the altar, and sometimes I feel as though I can even see his spirit trail.

And what an altar it is. 300 feet tall and a hundred wide, it holds the name of every fallen pureblood from the beginning of time until the present. I've read every name countless times, sometimes out of boredom, and other times out of fear that I might forget my brothers and sisters if I didn't.

The sound of footsteps creeps up behind me, and I turn to see the other two Archangels staring at me curiously.

"Back so soon? We didn't expect you for another day." Uzziel stands on her tip-toes and plants a kiss on my cheek. "I hope the humans didn't kick you out early."

I glance around, but no other angels are in our immediate vicinity. "Not quite, but many things have transpired."

Raphael stands and listens while I recount the happenings of the last few days, and Uzziel wraps her arm around mine, leaning against me lightly.

"...and then there's the matter of what happened when Jason Hiro was attacked by his son. The anti-energy hit him, and it didn't affect him."

Raphael raises an eyebrow. "Goodness, you had me running scared for a moment. And here I thought it would turn out he was, in fact, a demon! Ha ha ha!"

Uzziel swings around on my arm. "Hmm... hmm... so he didn't react at all? Not even a little bit?"

"Nope. Well, he did flinch slightly, and he clutched his chest, but Benjamin Brown assured me it was just a startled reaction. If he were a demon though, then he would have surely died, or at least suffered a grievous wound from a blast at such a close range."

"A demon, is it..." Raphael pauses and stares silently at the ground. "There is something, a memory from the distant past. I feel it at the edge of my mind, but it may have been swept away by the sands of time. Something about... humans with magical power."

I have no idea what he's talking about, but Uzziel jumps away from me and gasps. "Th-that's it! You're on the right path, brother! I remember too!...Sort of."

Her jump from confident to uncertain in a single second makes me chuckle. "You don't remember either, then? What use is that to me?"

Suddenly I feel gears turning in my head. "Wait, hold a moment... are you... I feel something too. Not just a faint memory, but something I shouldn't have forgotten at all. Except... I have."

Raphael's brow is bent with consternation. "Indeed. Troubling. My memory isn't as bad as I make it out to be, yet there is a hollow spot, plain as day."

"Right. I can remember the names of every brother and sister from eons past, but not this one detail? Why?" A sickening churning fills my body, and I have to sit on a marble bench nearby. "Why can't I remember?"

Uzziel speaks, her voice almost a whisper. "If the perfect memories of an angel are unable to recall something... there is only one culprit, brothers."

"Memory manipulation. Someone has changed our brains to remove the knowledge we once had. But who? And why?"

Raphael's question makes me feel even more uneasy.

"Is this hole created by magic... or by technology? It exists. I feel it now. But what does it mean?"

"No point guessing. Ask the King if he knows when you speak with him. It could be benign." Raphael's words are not reassuring.

The three of us feel cold shivers in our bodies, but the feeling passes, and we finally have to laugh the moment off. "Well, um, in any case... I'll be going now." Uzziel hops over and hugs me before walking away to do... whatever it is she does. I think she plays games with the humans when nobody is looking, but then, she's always been sympathetic to their plights.

Raphael sits down on the bench beside me. "Well, since you're going in to speak with the King, I had a favor to ask of you."

"Hmm? What?" He suddenly seems so solemn. This is what I'm used to from him, but somehow it's more intense than usual.

"Regarding... the... the new life King Zeus is creating." Raphael grips his staff firmer. "I haven't wanted to tell you this yet, but with all the changes to the energy supply lately... well, there has been something of concern on my mind."

"Would you prefer Uzziel not know?"

The fact he waited for her to leave is telling. Whatever is on his mind must be of grave importance.

"You misunderstand, Gabriel. I don't want even *you* to possess this knowledge. The fact the King might know it shakes me to my very core. I have only held this secret all my life silently,

knowing it could save us if we were ever truly in a world ending bind."

He continues. "Do you know why they call me Raphael the Wise, and Raphael the Eldest, despite the fact that all of the Archangels are the same age?"

Funny he asks that. "No. I just assumed you were... uh... wise. And knowledgeable."

Raphael lunges his hand out suddenly and grabs my wrist, making me squirm in surprise. "Wrong!" He hisses under his breath. "It is because I am the keeper of a secret power, something the angels swore never to use again, under any circumstance. The knowledge I possess has filled me with a dread unlike any you could ever feel, from the day I swore the sacred oath, to this very moment. The horrible pain I felt muddled every smile, every laugh, every single moment of happiness..."

His hand, still gripping mine, begins to tremble. "And... the fact that I must share this knowledge with you... it hurts me. I am breaking a sacred pact, not because I want to... but because I must. You alone are the only brother of mine with a strong enough will to never abuse this... this horrendous knowledge."

Raphael tears up and wipes them away a moment later. I take the time to prod him. "What is it? If this information is so awful, perhaps I shouldn't know-" I catch myself and stop what I'm saying immediately.

Raphael has a secret, something tearing him apart from the inside out. Whatever it is, I would be selfish to let only him carry the burden. It must be killing him that only he knows.

"Sorry. Raphael, brother, if you wish to tell me, I will listen. Do not bear this cross on your own."

Raphael, in spite of the pain he must be feeling, cracks a smile. "Haha... a cross... funny. Michael would find that very amusing."

"Yes. I believe he might." I touch the ring on my finger gently, and finally, Raphael gathers up the will to speak again.

"Creating a new angel... is impossible."

"Huh?" I blink in surprise. "Impossible? But... but Zeus is doing it."

"Indeed. Rather, I should say that it is not impossible... but that the method for doing so has been sealed away, locked only in my mind, since the beginning of time."

My teeth clench together of their own accord. "What is this method, then?"

"Speak of this to no-one." Raphael hisses the words out again, shooting a suspicious glance at two angels talking to each other across the Great Hall. They're several hundred feet away

though, and the Great Hall does not echo voices at all. "Creating an angel requires two things, Gabriel. It requires a tremendous amount of energy, as Zeus is receiving now... but... it also requires..."

Seconds pass before he forces himself to finish. "...fresh life energy."

So that's what it was. For some reason, the revelation is revolting, but not world-shattering as I had expected. "I don't understand, brother. What do you mean by fresh?"

Raphael turns away from me. "In other words, on top of the thought energy that Zeus is obtaining from the humans and Volgrim, it's likely he is killing humans to gain life energy for each angel he creates."

I finally understand what he means. "Zeus is killing humans? How many would it take to create an angel?"

"Just one." The words limp out of his mouth weakly. "That is all. But the human who is killed for the purpose of creating an angel will not be revived as an angel once they die. It requires their entire soul."

"A grim revelation for sure. Still, not to be callous, Raphael, but even if it does require a fresh life energy... it's just one human life. What difference does it make when they have trillions?"

Raphael surprises me again by smiling. "Indeed, you are correct. Just one human soul is a trifle. Even I could not pretend to care about a single person. But that is not the problem, Gabriel. The issue lies in him possessing the forbidden knowledge."

Raphael's grip tightens on my wrist as he sends a mental image through our spirits.

In front of my eyes, an image of the cosmos, bright and radiant, fills the room around me. The bystanders and other angels fade away. Raphael's voice speaks, a soft whisper that quickly escalates into a universe shattering BOOM.

"Behold... the universe! A wondrous place, filled with all manner of sights and wonders!"

Raphael's face becomes a soft, half-faded shape against the backdrop of the cosmos. "Once, there was a time when angels were as numerous as the stars in the sky. Even I know not how we first realized our existence. Besides the angels, there were the Dragons, and the Titans! The three great powers fought for control of the galaxy, but angels were always at a disadvantage. The other species could use their inexhaustible stamina and magical energy to fight and rest, fight and rest... but whenever an angel fought, he would run the risk of draining himself and dying!"

"How then, brother, do you suppose the angels could fight a war of attrition, when attrition was our greatest weakness, hmm?!" Raphael's voice is thundering and accusatory now, aimed at

me as if it were my fault the three races warred.

I don't get a chance to respond. "It's simple! We stole the energy of others for ourselves! We ripped the souls from the Dragons, and the Titans, and we added them to our own consciousness! We created more and more angels until soon we began to run out of Dragons and Titans to fight!"

"AND THEN WHAT DO YOU THINK HAPPENED?!" Raphael screams at me and the forms of the three species fighting melts away. "OF COURSE! THE ONLY BEINGS LEFT TO TAKE ENERGY FROM WERE OURSELVES!!!"

A colossal image of angels stabbing each other, tearing wings off, and otherwise mutilating each other in horrible ways plays out in my mind. For every angel born, ten more are murdered by their brethren. I feel anxious and fearful as the scenes play out in my mind.

Raphael's voice quiets down. "Do you remember, Gabriel? Of course, you don't. We were the first angels born, we killed the most, and we lived together, but in spite of your battle prowess and my mind, I knew what we were doing was wrong. The cycle would only result in the extinction of our kind. And so, I called for a cease-fire, not just with the angels, but with the Titans too. The Dragons were nowhere to be seen, or I would have invited them as well."

The pieces finally click in my mind. "That's why you created the demons, then? And the humans?"

"Yes."

The infinite cosmos of the past fades away, and moments later I'm back on that bench, sitting beside my brother once more. A deep sadness lingers in his eyes, one I haven't seen as long as I've known him.

"I agreed, as the arbiter of peace, to carry the burden for our people. We would wipe away wars, anger, sadness. The Titans, being superior to us when it came to the matters of energy creation and collection, devised a system to give us energy in smaller, but more stable quantities, via a species serving only as cattle for our needs. In exchange, everyone would give up their memories of the past. Only I had to live, knowing what we had done."

Raphael lifts his head up and turns back to look at the altar behind us. "These names... they are nothing. I remember countless others before them. Angels whose existences you don't know of. Tens of thousands of angels that would be archangels like ourselves. You will never see them or speak to them."

My heart feels like it's made of lead. I can't even process what he's telling me. "So... if Zeus knows about... the process to create an angel..."

"Then he may know of our ultimate technique. Being a god -the descendant of Titan and angel- he holds the power to use our abilities, in addition to titan powers. He may just possess the ability to steal souls."

"I'll... I'll talk to him about this, then..."

"NO!" Raphael almost jumps out of his seat. "Absolutely not! You are not to speak of this to anyone, and certainly not Zeus! I am only telling you this... so you will be on your guard. You must be aware of what I know. With this, we can ensure no tomfoolery is going on."

I swallow long and hard. "I understand. Thank you, for telling me this."

"Oh, don't thank me. This is not a reward, but a curse. Above all other things, you must never use this knowledge for evil. You must *never* use this power."

Raphael shivers before standing up. "Ah, I had almost forgotten... the Volgrim are trying to establish a warp-gate to Heaven, just as the humans have done. I strictly oppose it, so just remember that, if Zeus tries to talk you into anything."

"I will, brother." I eye him unsmilingly as he limps away. We do not embrace each other this time, for now we must share in sorrow together.

The power to rip souls from other beings. How... barbaric. Horrific. And the way Raphael looked at me when he spoke of it... I must have been violent before my memory was wiped.

Just how many souls have *I* taken?

Part 425b: I, Human

I love public speaking. Most people hate it, and I did once as well, but after I grew used to it, it became a thrill that I couldn't get enough of. I long ago stopped wordsmithing *calm* on myself to steady my nerves, as now I have shifted the butterflies in my stomach into energy that sustains me. Well, not enough energy I suppose. I'm fatigued from drafting this speech throughout all of last night.

I whisper a word under my breath as I stride forward. "**Alert.**" Immediately, the feeling of exhaustion vanishes, and I blink my eyes, wondering how I can instantaneously make such an intense need for sleep disappear. Of course, I can't just abuse my power like that. It's sure to have long-term consequences on my physical and mental health. Though, strangely, I don't think I've ever tested it out... how do I know that?

My black dress shoes *clomp* on the floor as I stride forward, all the while wondering how I sometimes know things I shouldn't. Memories come to me from nowhere, like dandelion seeds scattered into the wind. Their contents may not even be correct, but somehow it is better just to believe them. Why waste my time questioning everything?

I step up to the podium, holding my datapad loosely the whole time. This speech center, built to my specifications over half a year ago, allows me to broadcast messages to everyone in my empire all at once. A huge arena towers before me, stacked to the brim with people sitting on the mahogany benches to watch, though a large chunk of them are holograms instead of fleshy beings.

Holograms. That reminds me of Marie. Where has she been for a year? I haven't seen or heard from her at all, and the hairs on the back of my neck never stop standing on end as a result. I'd be a lot happier if she were dead, but I can't locate her, and therefore wouldn't know if I killed her even if I used my wordsmithing to try.

Ah, I need to stop thinking about other things. Focus. This speech isn't going to deliver itself.

How many people and holograms are in this amphitheater? Fifty thousand? There's a white-noise filter beaming forth, creating an invisible wall in front of me, so the audience's considerable noise is toned down to a level where I can barely even hear them. It has the unintended side effect of making the audience seem like a bunch of mimes, opening and closing their mouths silently, but I'll deal with it.

I stop in front of the podium and wait for exactly four seconds, and the audience ceases their chattering to sit at rapt attention.

"Good morning to all members of Humanity. As per the promise I made last year, I am giving this speech today as part of my bi-monthly update regarding the operations of our vast empire. As everyone is aware, the Senate and I passed a resolution one year ago to allow unlimited travel to and from Heaven. Angels and humans could visit each other's domains freely, as much or as little as they pleased."

"I am glad to say that my primary goal succeeded. People have been able to see their deceased loved ones, and for the most part, things were going smoothly. Unfortunately, due to the actions of a few, the majority must lose out. As with all good things, it only takes a tiny minority of citizens abusing their privileges to sour the water for the rest. People have been killing themselves to become angels, which lowers the energy we can give our closest allies."

I pause to take a breath before continuing.

"Comrades, I know that the overwhelming majority of you are intelligent. You understand the dangers of such reckless actions. If humans kill themselves any more than they already have, the amount of energy flowing to the angels will slow dramatically. In the worst case scenario, it could invert, causing the angels to lose more energy than we can give. And what then? You will have killed yourself, only for you to end up in a situation worsening every second. On top of that, you will bring doom upon the angels, or force them to purge some of their own kind, as well as other humans who have died, in order to make up the difference."

"All I am asking is that people realize the folly of their actions. By killing yourself just to gain wings or whatever other trifling benefits you think you deserve, you permanently give up living in our glorious empire! Moreover, you are likely to bring about the deaths of friends and family from the past who are just trying to live peacefully, separate from ours."

The majority of the audience nods along with my words. I'm not wrong, after all, and they all know how important thought-energy is for the angels, and for themselves. Their greed is incredibly annoying.

"There is another danger too, being brought about by the people killing themselves. To maintain the energy needed to keep all angels alive, Zeus has been forced to accept an offer from the Volgrim, and they are now giving the angels thought-energy. Think of what this means. We lose clout with our closest allies, and the angels are forced to initiate better terms with the Volgrim. Do you suppose the Volgrim will give up their energy freely? No!"

I rap my knuckles on the podium in front of me. "There is a price for every choice, a consequence for every action. I place the blame for much of what has happened in the last year on myself. I should have researched the potential downsides of allowing unlimited travel between the human and angelic realms, but I did not. That guilt will be on my shoulders for a

long time to come. However, because of what the Volgrim are now asking of the Angels, which is a warp-gate directly to Heaven from the Volgrim homeworld, this puts humanity in a precarious situation, diplomatically speaking. A warp-gate to Heaven would allow the Volgrim a chance to strike directly at the heart of our Empire, should the worst ever come to happen."

"A warp-gate is a security threat that I, as Supreme Commander, can no longer ignore. Therefore, to attempt to mollify the angels and gods, and to try and repair much of the damage caused by my policies... I am going to restrict travel between our dimension and the Angels', once again. However, it will still be less strict than it used to be. It will require a special permit to travel from our world to Heaven, and vice-versa, but it will be much easier than it used to be before my policies were enacted, rest assured."

I slide my finger across the datapad, checking the upcoming notes quickly to make sure I'm on track. So far, so good.

This speech is going better than I expected.

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Some people complain about jobs like these, but as for me, I like to put my feet up and relax. I've been in the military my whole life, but since the last major war was about fifty million years ago, I haven't had any action in a long time. I mean, philosophy is better anyway. Who likes fighting? Not me.

I sometimes joke with my crew that I did all my fighting already, in another life, and now I've been reincarnated into my current role as a reward for my hard work. They get a real kick out of that. Imagine, orbiting the same planet for a hundred thousand years, just to make sure some lousy prisoners don't escape. What does the military think they're going to do, jump up and fly away by flapping their arms? Men, I tell you what. They never use their brains.

Well, okay, fine, so there was that *incident* last year. A single ship got past me while I was sleeping, but it only had *one* prisoner!

Bla bla bla, Beatrix you had one job and you couldn't do it, nyeh meh bleh. They expect me to be at the ready all the time? Come on. There is nothing out here. A whopping *one* prisoner has escaped in the last million years, and she took out a small platoon's worth of guards on the surface. If a bunch of men couldn't handle a single measly girl, maybe they deserved to get their asses kicked. I never liked the Warden anyway. For a woman, she was a real prick.

Hell with it. I'm glad they're all dead.

Gah! I can't even enjoy this book! I just want to sit here and read about *The Adventures of Tom Sawyer* but all I can think about is one stupid incident that happened over a year ago. It's

the only stain on my otherwise spotless career! Well okay, there was that whole Goldesh uprising thing, but do they expect me to come in at the last minute and make everything all better? Get real!

I tell you, sometimes I just have to wonder if-

"Captain Beatrix!" Ezekiel, my scanning officer, spins around in his chair, alarm on his face. "There's a Cruiser entering Tarus jurisdiction from hyperspace."

"Yeah? What about it?" I shoot him an annoyed glare. "We see prisoner transports all the time. They're probably dropping off some loon who snapped and killed a mouthy scanning officer."

He doesn't smile. "This ship has no identification. It's not a part of any disclosed ship models. And... its design... it doesn't look human-made."

Finally. Something to do.

I toss the paperback to my side, and it slams on the titanium deck-plate with a satisfying *thud*. "Open a channel."

My communications officer turns to look at me almost immediately. "I already tried, ma'am. No response."

"Move to intercept, then. We need to know what their business is before we let them proceed."

The looks of alarm on everyone's faces is killing my mood. "Calm down. Our military has many secret projects, and several of those include prototype ships, including Infiltrator-class ships in case we need to sneak past Volgrim defenses. This is probably a drill to test our readiness after the... last incident."

"Sorry, Captain. I didn't mean to overreact." Ezekiel breathes a small sigh of relief.

The chief security officer, calm as always, is next to speak. "Shields are powered to full."

Seconds pass, and I stare at the image of this new ship uneasily. It's huge, probably twice the size of the NFC Luminance, my ship. I don't see any weapons, but appearances can be deceiving.

Ezekiel nearly jumps out of his seat. "What the hell?! The ship just fired a projectile behind itself. It's moving at one-quarter the speed of ligh- huh?!"

He doesn't need to say anything else. Everyone on the bridge gasps audibly as a massive wormhole explodes into existence all at once. Before I can even process what's happening, a different Cruiser class appears from its maw, and then another, and another, and...

"Red alert! Send a message to the other ships in this sector! It's an invasion!" My fingers dig into the arms of my chair, but the worst hasn't even begun.

One of the ships that just arrived initiates a split-second micro-jump, blasting past us and coming within a thousand miles of Tarus II. It rains a cannon volley onto the planet's surface, and the scanners scream an alarm in response.

"The main prison facility is being attacked! What is your response, Captain?"

Shit shit shit... I don't know what's going on. Some kind of targeted attack? Why hit the prison? I'm not familiar with Volgrim ship structure since they're so reclusive, but there can't be anyone else who would do this, unless it's a coup from humanity itself. And that's an absurd notion.

"Distract that lead ship! I don't know why they're attacking the prison, but they must have a reason! Hit them with everything we've got! We must hold out until reinforcements arrive!"

I'm suddenly thrown from my chair and face plant on the ground as our ship violently lurches forward. A second later, Ezekiel coughs, and I look up to see blood trickling down his head. One of my crew pulls me up to my feet, and Ezekiel delivers a report. "They aren't going to make that order easy, Captain. The other ships are attacking us all at once."

"Retreat, then! We can't fight ten-" I glance up at the viewscreen and feel an ache in my gut as more ships continue streaming into the sector. "-ah, a *hundred* Volgrim warships. We're no good to the Empire dead. Let's get out of here!"

The ship rattles as a massive volley smashes into us again. I just hope I live to regret this.

* * *

"Gabriel! Gabriel!"

A male angel howls my name, his voice filled with alarm. The scroll in my hand seems less pressing than whatever he has to say, so I turn to Raphael. "Ah, excuse me a moment."

"Certainly." Raphael doesn't turn away but instead looks across the Temple toward whoever is causing the commotion. I turn to look as well, and something fills me with dread. It's Zarall. He isn't one to enter the Temple, ever.

Zarall charges past everyone, shoving one angel out of his way forcibly. Something has him spooked, and I don't like it one bit.

"I need help! They're appearing all at once! Thousands, tens of thousands! There's a riot going on! We need to suppress this right now!" He babbles incoherently, but I manage to make out what he's saying, mostly.

"Humans are dying?" Raphael asks the question before I get a chance. "Mass suicides?"

"No! No no no!!" Zarall is at the edge of panic. "All the humans are previously registered Class I convicts! Criminals! They're all from Tarus II, the humans' highest maximum security prison!"

"Merciful saints!" The curse escapes my lips without a second thought. "Perhaps a guard revolt in the prisons? Maybe the prisoners are killing themselves to escape justice?"

"I don't know, but I need help NOW! Get every single angel on the case!" Zarall beckons hurriedly, then rethinks and instead grabs my shirt to haul me along.

I turn back to Raphael as Zarall drags me away. "Don't bother! Tell all the other angels to stay clear! I'll handle this myself! I'm not going to let some half-breeds tear Heaven apart!"

Raphael appears in front of me, moving far too quickly for an old man his age. "The hell you will. Don't underestimate them just because they aren't pure-bloods. That cocky attitude will be the death of you."

I take a step back, startled. "S-sorry. Right, well, send help then. I'll do what I can."

"Yes, you will, brother." Raphael turns around and starts walking to the throne room. "I will fetch Zeus. We may need his power."

"Good. I'll be back soon." I continue running to the door, much to Zarall's relief.

"Follow me! Stop dawdling!"

"I'm coming! Gods!"

A minute later, we've already flown over to the Arrival Platform, and the sight there boggles my mind. Tens of thousands? No... there must be a million humans here already, and more keep appearing, piling onto each other, one by one as they die and are reborn as winged demi-gods.

"What is the meaning of all this...?"

* * *

"I can understand why many might consider the Volgrim to be a non-issue, and I say, to those citizens who believe this... you are wrong. The Volgrim are dangerous beyond anything we can imagine. Certainly, we've had tens of millions of years of strained peace, but this is much more akin to a cold war. We aim our weapons at them, and they at us. Any appearance of civility is just that, a false veneer. If I were to allow them to construct a warp-gate into Heaven, this would surely come back to nip humanity in the toe someday."

The Supreme Commander, Jason Hiro, continues droning on and on and all I can do is lie on my stomach and wait. I'm not waiting for anything in particular, but when the moment feels right, I'll do what I have to.

I still remember that feeling of cold terror. Two nights ago, Steven Feldmann called me, and he was absolutely frantic. The more he talked, the more uncontrollable my shaking became. Pieces and clues began to click in my mind. The weird way Commander Hiro has been acting, all these odd policy choices... and even the manner in which he fired me. Why *did* he get rid of me, all of a sudden?

It's obvious to me now. Jason Hiro isn't a human. He's a demon imposter. Every action he's taken has served to bring instability to human society.

Don't hold back, Stephanie. His face might be the same as the man you knew for thousands of years, but he is not that man. He isn't a man at all, but a servant of darkness.

Steven's words come back to me, but now I hesitate to carry out his will. It's not that I don't want to kill this monster, but what comes next? I'm unlikely to escape. I might be an amazing sniper, but I'm terrible at lying, and the security council will sentence me to eternal torture when they catch me.

Or will they? If I kill him, then I'll also expose him as a demon, and that will clear Steven's name! He can be free once again!

But what do I want? Even if the best scenario happens... what will I do after this? I love Steven. We might seem distant to some people, but he taught me everything I knew. He pulled me from the lower levels and brought me to the safety of the upper section, then showed me the art of being the perfect spy. All so he could save humanity from those trying to throw us to the hounds.

He used me. I know that. Steven could have picked anyone, man or woman. I'm not special. Maybe it's Stockholm Syndrome... I know he doesn't care for me in that way, but I still love him dearly. Perhaps that's why I'm so frustrated by Lora. Before he met her, Steven always spent time with me, whether showing me new tricks from the baseball manuals he coveted, and telling me all those cute little things about his life. Now, all he does is prattle on about 'Lora this' and 'Lora that'. If only he knew how much I hated hearing about her.

"The angels have never turned their back on us! Far be it for humanity to allow them to suffer under an energy drought!"

Jason keeps talking, and I roll my eyes. The people in the auditorium below me don't go all the way to the back row. From my position in this dimly lit room, I'm almost in total darkness.

Hidden behind a chair that rises a foot above me, one would have to look closely to see the barrel of my Magmellion sticking an inch out from between the two chairs.

Carefully, I adjust my sight on Jason again. It's a nitpicky thing, I just have to double and triple check to make sure everything is perfect. This room is sealed from the outside world, so luckily the wind won't be an issue. The downward angle means I have to compensate slightly, and I can't just fire a test shot to make sure my positioning isn't off...

Damn. I get so flustered when I'm by myself. It's easier for me to calm down around Steven... but if I don't kill this demon imposter, Steven's going to be in prison for millions of years. Sedition, crimes against the state, treason... they're throwing the book at him. I just hope they haven't shipped him off to Tarus II. Fuck. That facility doesn't allow prisoners ever to have visitors. If he ends up in there, I'll probably never see him again.

Jason waves his hands dramatically, but I'm not paying attention to what he says right now. Careless! I need to focus. What would Steven think if he knew I was losing my cool? I've never done a hit job before, but I can hit a target a mile away flawlessly, as long as I take my time. As for something the size of a human head? Piece of cake.

Yeah. Cake. After this, I need to see if they have cake at the- STOP!

That's it. No more time for distractions. As soon as he's still for just a moment, I'm taking the shot. I check the scope and the bullet chamber one last time. Is the anti-energy 'hull-buster' bullet loaded? Yes. This gun could kill a man inside a hover-tank as long as the bullet hits.

No regrets.

...And just as I say that, he starts gesticulating wildly. He's like a cringey Sunday school preacher. Steven used to show me clips and footage from the ancient times, and this is just like them. He's just delaying the inevitable with all this waving nonsense!

My heart slams in my chest. Jason stops just for a moment. He calms down to stare at the audience seriously.

"I cannot stress this enough..."

Whatever he has to say, it's over. I'm done listening. Go back to Hell from whence you came, *demon*.

My finger squeezes the trigger, and at that instant, he turns to look directly at me. *What?! How?*

PIFF.

The sound of a gas-compressed bullet snaps out of the barrel, and in the next instant, his head recoils violently, the bullet smashes him backward, pounding the back of his skull into the

ground with tremendous force. The audience goes dead silent as horror fills the room.

I... did it.

I killed the Supreme Commander.

Part 426b: Route B Finale

Jason! Watch out! I yell into his mind to get his attention, and he turns to look where I indicated, but-

PIFF.

A sound much like a balloon popping fills the room, and Jason's head is knocked backward.

I can only stare in stunned silence as he falls to the ground. My still-invisible orb flops out of the shoulder-wrapped gurney at his side and rolls a few feet away, but nobody notices.

Jason. Jason! Are you okay?!

I send my thoughts to him, but I get nothing in response. Several men and women rush the stage, all part of his private security squad. "Surround him! Sweep the area! The assassin can't have gone far! Someone call a medical team!" One of the men barks orders and the others make a human shield around their fallen Commander.

From my position, I can see the entire world around me in a 360-degree sphere, all at once. I've already spotted the assassin, just before she fired. *Stephanie Guillermo*. Of all the people, I never expected her to be the culprit. She's hiding behind a chair in the darkness, but her escape route is already cut off. Her killing intent makes her visible to me like a spotlight in a pitch black void. She'll be arrested, but already it's too late for Jason. He's-

"His eyes! They've opened! Commander!" A female guard leans down beside him, but the moment she touches him, she *explodes*. Her body blasts outward as if a meteor had impacted her in the chest.

"What just-" A guard opposite her corpse, now blown into a billion pieces, stares in shock. He's covered from head to toe in human entrails, each piece of the woman slowly oozing down his body like a pack of ravenous worms.

Head... hurts. Stop... laughing... Jason's voice appears in my mind, telepathically. Every person in the room freezes, including the men and women surrounding him.

"C-commander?" The head guard slowly takes a step back. "Why do I hear his voice... in my head?"

SILENCE! EVERYONE SHUT UP!

Jason's voice roars like a hurricane, the sound so loud that it makes even me reel back in surprise. By the time I've regained my mental faculties, I can only gasp in surprise. All the

guards surrounding him have been blown to pieces, and the floor is permanently repainted red from their blood.

You think you can hide from me, WHORE?!

Jason rises into the air dramatically, his arms and legs dangling at his sides uselessly. His eyes are bloodshot. The expression on his face is like a crazed Rottweiler. He looks completely insane, in a way I couldn't have imagined in a million years.

A moment later, Stephanie screams as he yanks her toward him with terrifying force, destroying the chair she had been hiding behind.

"Oh my god! Steven was right! You're a- GUHK!" She doesn't get to finish her sentence. Her leg tears from her body and pummels her savagely, as Jason beats her to death with her extremities. He casually drops her afterward, letting her body hit the floor with a sickening *crunch*.

I thought I told everyone to KEEP QUIET!

The audience is trying to make a break for the exits, but he doesn't let them. The doors slam shut, aided by his telekinesis, and all the people in the room are left to cower as he stares at Stephanie's mutilated corpse.

I don't understand what's going on. Jason survived that bullet hit, but it must have given him a concussion or messed with his mind somehow. He's acting like a madman. In all the time I've been around him, he's never hinted at having anger like this.

Jason. You've just revealed your powers to all of humanity. Everyone is watching this broadcast.

I try to talk some sense into him, but instead, a smile crosses over his face. His eyes are dead, empty, unseeing.

You too, Blaarjiim? Even you can't can't stop BACKTALKING ME!

A blast of telekinesis sends me and my orb flying. I smash against the wall, but it doesn't hurt me at all. I can't feel any pain, and it would take a lot more power than that to destroy my orb.

One courageous man steps forward from the audience, a military man by the look of his uniform. "Monster! Demon! What the hell are you?!" He fires a plasma shot at Jason, but the Wordsmith dodges easily, his body jerked to the side by telekinesis. A moment later, he rips the man's arm off and crumples the gun into the size of a marble.

General Zhao? And here I thought you were loyal.

Zhao screams in pain and falls to his knees, futilely clutching at his shoulder stump. "I-I'm not loyal to a demon! Burn in hell!"

Hm... heh... hehehe.... Jason's quiet laugh whispers to my mind and the sound of it chills me to my core. It's sinister, unlike anything I've ever heard. *Burn? You want me to burn?! No! YOU will taste the flame!*

Jason finally speaks out loud, and just for a single word. " **INFERNO!** "

A tremendous fire blast shoots out of him, engulfing the room in a heat like the birth of the universe. Zhao dies, as do thousands of others. Screams, cut off a second later by the rushing walls of flame, fill the room. Eventually, all is still. From my position among the charred benches lining the upper section, I can only see a single layer of a mountain of bodies.

Some are alive? Very well. For too long I have given up everything for ungrateful leeches, but now it is time. Your energy is mine!

What life I can still sense in the room is snuffed out like the embers of a thousand candles in a rainstorm. Jason drains the energy from everyone present, then wordsmiths one final word. " **Explosion!** "

As the building collapses around me, I watch in disbelief as he hovers over to a far door, rips it from its hinges, and leaves. His cackle fades from my mind as the distance between us grows, and soon I can no longer hear him at all.

Farewell... Jason Hiro. I am not unhappy with what you've become. I only wonder if soon, you will come to regret that which has just transpired.

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Everyone in the classroom watches the viewscreen, unable to look away. Jason Hiro, Supreme Commander of the United Earth Forces, transforms from human to monster in several seconds. While delivering a speech to all of humanity, someone attempts to assassinate him, only for him to demonstrate a frightening level of magical power. Somehow, he manages to tear apart everyone in the room without moving a muscle.

Only once he levitates into the air, using an unseen power, does the mental image of a Supreme Commander shatter in our minds. The unnatural way his head lolls about, the dead limbs hanging from his sides and below him; whatever is moving him about, it isn't something a human mind can comprehend.

"Timothy... is that... your father?" Melissa, one of the girls in my classroom, turns around slowly to look at me. "What- what's wrong with him?"

I stare silently at her for a few moments. I don't know what's happening. I don't have an answer to her question. The demon who is killing off the leaders of humanity can't possibly be my father. He would never do anything like that.

But my mother acted shocked last year when he demonstrated his magical powers in front of me. Not shocked that he had such abilities, but shocked that he would *show me*. For whatever the reason, it was a secret only the two of them knew. Why? What reasons could they have?

"Tim? Tim? Are you here?" James waves his hand in front of my face. I blink slowly to clear my mind, and look at him now. He's trying to act calm, but he's looking at me with fear in his eyes. The terror of the unknown. If my father is a monster, then surely I am too. That's what he's thinking.

There's only one answer I can give. "That man isn't my father. I'm leaving."

I ignore everyone staring at me and slide from my chair, then start marching to the door. Melissa grabs my jacket cuff as I walk past her. "Wait! W-where are you going?"

I pull away from her grasp. I can't feel any emotions right now. I just feel empty. "My father, that man... he just killed off the entire audience. Senators were there. The people that hold the Human Empire together. This... this is the worst case scenario. I need to find out who is left."

James has a look of awe on his face. "You're going to take control?"

"I hope not, James. No matter what happens next, just remember one important thing: Jason Hiro, the *thing* you saw on that broadcast, is not my father. He's the enemy of Humanity. I will stop him myself if I have to."

The class watches in silence as I stride out the room. The teacher, perhaps also fearful of me, makes no move to stop me.

It's only after I hear the room door close behind me, and the sound of my plaid shoes echoing off the walls of the hallway greets my ears, that I can finally feel a tinge of emotion.

Rage.

He can't be my father. It's a mistake. The demons are tricking us. That has to be it. I don't know what happened to my real father, but that thing needs to be put down.

Suddenly the entire building shakes violently and I trip over my feet, stumble forward, and bash my knees on the cold white tiled floor. The school shakes again and again, each time tossing me around like a well-practiced juggler.

My wrist-communicator vibrates. A call for me? I send a mental signal through its electric sensors to answer the call, and a voice I didn't expect greets me.

"Timothy Hiro. My name is Benjamin Brown. Have you watched the national broadcast yet?"

I clench my fists together, and my nails dig deep into my palms. "Yes."

Benjamin's voice is tight. "Humanity is under attack. The Volgrim are assaulting every system and sector, all at once. Your father- he just... well, he killed off everyone. With Jason Hiro assumed to be an enemy of humanity, you are the highest ranking human left."

His words make my stomach roil. "What?! Everyone? There must be someone left!"

I can almost hear Benjamin shake his head. "No. We need you at Central Comman-" He's cut off momentarily, and I listen to an explosion in the background. A second later he coughs into the microphone. "Shit. I'll do what I can, but we need to re-establish a formal command structure immediately. We don't have time to waste. Get over here!"

I jump to my feet and start dashing down the halls. "I'm on my way."

This time, when the stratoscraper shakes, I don't lose my footing. Humanity is depending on me. I can't let them down!

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The line goes silent as Timothy Hiro assures me he's on his way. Once my focus is no longer on him, I return my attention to the people around me. The sounds of men and women rushing back and forth almost drown out the sound of explosions beyond the walls of our megascraper. Central Command, while filled with people rushing around to communicate with the upper fleets, also has no leadership presently.

I'm a nobody. I worked for Marie, but I was just her agent, her right-hand man. I'm not trained in what to do here. I'm doing what I can, of course, but it's clear the people here don't look up to me in the same way they did to their Supreme Commander.

Damn. Why did you do that, Jason? I didn't think you were mentally weak enough to crack after a failed assassination attempt. But then, the way his arms were dangling at his sides, was he injured in the attack? That might explain his erratic behavior.

I don't have time to think about it though. A woman, Angela, calls out my name. "Benjamin! The forward fleet just made it back!"

"Great. Get me a feed to whoever's in charge, and I want data on the fleet parameters, stat."

I shove past several people to get to her, and by the time I make it across, she's already sending a communication signal to the lead ship. "Here. Take the call. I'll run the numbers for you."

Four painful seconds pass before the bloodied face of a young man appears on the holo-screen. "Central Command?! We don't have an admiral or even a general on call! The best we've got is a lieutenant, and she's trying to run three fleets! Get the goddamn suits up here! We're taking heavy fire! Casualties are in the tens of thousands!"

He doesn't know what Jason did yet? "Son, what rank are you?"

"Private, third-class, sir."

"Congratulations. You're in charge of your ship. The, uh, the enemy launched a surprise attack. The Supreme Commander is down, and so are all of the generals, admirals, and even the scum-sucking politicians. We're short handed, and now's as good a time as ever for fresh faces to step up and become heroes, young man."

The poor kid, barely even a hundred thousand years old by the looks of him, gapes at me in horror. "Are you kidding?! I don't have the experience to lead a goddamn armada! Is there no one else left?"

I stare him right in the eyes. "Take command, Private. I'm temporarily promoting you to Lieutenant. Make your species proud."

Poor sap. Tears fill his eyes. "Yes... yes, sir."

I cut the call off as Angela appears at my side, setting a datapad before me. "Fourteen Cruiser-class ships, and one Artemis-class. No capital ships within five light-years."

"Fine. Send every available fighter and bomber up there. Execute as many attack runs as it takes. If the Volgrim wipe Earth out, it's all over."

A woman screams from behind me, and her voice is cut off abruptly, so I spin around to see what's going on. To my horror, ten armored soldiers have just appeared in the middle of Central Command. The suits they're wearing cover them from head to toe, just like our Hypersuit Commandos. They begin blasting plasma shots at everyone they see, causing panic and mayhem as everyone dashes for cover.

"Son of a bitch! Volgrim in Central Command! Everyone, get down! Battle stations!" I throw Angela to the ground and execute a perfect diving roll to shelter.

A disembodied male voice speaks, the monstrous sound hissing through the air like ice tossed onto a raging fire. "Volgrim? Now I'm offended."

Two more figures appear, both of them only a few feet in front of me. I recognize them instantly. "Two Demon Emperors?!" I bring my holstered gun to bear on the closest, Beelzebub, and blast a shot of anti-energy right at his chest. Bael, the First Demon Emperor, jerks his hand forward, catches the shot, and the energy fizzles out harmlessly.

"That was impolite." Beelzebub says, as he glances down at his nails before looking back up at the chaos unfolding. "Everyone, please cease fighting for a moment. Royal Guardsmen, that includes you."

The sounds of plasma fire stop instantly, except for one of the armored warriors, who either ignores the order or didn't hear it. I listen with disgust as he continues firing and downs two more people in the room who aren't fast enough to escape in time.

Beelzebub crinkles his nose. "Bael, I did give an order, didn't I?"

"Yup. That's what I heard."

"And he's still shooting, isn't he?"

"Mhm."

Beelzebub scowls and looks at one of the other guards who stopped firing already. "How unfortunate. Kill the idiot."

A sudden chorus of blaster fire and one pitiful scream of pain is all I hear as the other nine warriors unload on their comrade, melting him down in an instant.

Beelzebub glares at me. "Stand up. Or kneel, I suppose. Come to think of it; I don't mind watching an ant grovel."

* * *

Both of the two sitting on their rumps slowly rise to meet my gaze. I don't know who they are, but the dark-skinned one seems to be the one in charge, given he was barking orders at the others when we arrived.

"You're colluding with the Volgrim, huh?" The male asks a pointless question, but the absurdity of it sends me a-titter.

"Hah! Bael, the humans truly are gullible. They haven't figured it out yet."

Bael smiles, with that stupid lopsided grin of his. "Kuhuhu, yeah, you got that right....Err, what didn't they figure out?"

He's such a buffoon. "That this invasion is entirely orchestrated by demons, of course. The Volgrim have nothing to do with it. I'm surprised none of these upper-level humans have realized this."

The tan man's face contorts into a delicious facsimile of horror and realization. "What?! The demons are behind this!? That's impossible! There are only 6,000 of you left! You can't possibly staff that many ships."

I wave my finger in his face. "Tut-tut, wrong again, on both counts. You're zero for three now. Care to try again?"

One of the nine Demon Royal Guards walks over to me, interrupting my gloating. "Third Emperor, we've rounded up all the humans in the office. What are your ord-"

I cut him off with a hiss in my voice. "What did you just call me? Open your helmet."

He opens it, as I ordered, and his face has an admirable stoicism to it. "I, ah, called you the... Third Emperor... sire."

Bael chuckles. "Dumbass. He's touchy about being the third, you know."

"I am not 'touchy'!" I shoot a glare at Bael but quickly bring my attention back to the Royal Guard. "In the future, you will address me as 'Emperor Beelzebub', is that understood?"

A drop of perspiration slides down his cheek, and his eyes flick over to his dead comrade. "Y-yes, Emperor Beelzebub."

"Wonderful. As for your orders, kill the humans you've rounded up. I'll leave these two alive for a moment."

The male human gawks at me. "What? No! Please, you can't do that! What do you want from us?"

My eye twitches. "I *can* do whatever I wish, worm. However, if you agree to order all of humanity's forces to stand down and surrender, I'll let your friends over there live. I care not whether they live or die, after all, only that demonkind is triumphant."

To his credit, he doesn't even consider the request. "Not a chance. You can kill us all. I'll turn into an angel, fly back, and kick your ass myself."

"Mmm. Yes, turning all of humanity into angels is part of the big picture. However, I wouldn't be so confident about the rump-kicking if I were you."

Bael nudges me with his elbow. "It was worth a try, Beelzy."

"Don't..." My teeth gnash together. "...call me... Beelzy."

"So sensitive." The human laughs nervously, but even I can easily see he's just trying to get a rise out of me.

The female, however, has been silent since we arrived. At the exact moment the pitiful cries of her friends being murdered sound off in the other room, she cracks. "No! Don't kill them! We'll do anything!"

"Sorry, woman. Yama's orders regarding this operation are absolute. Now if you'd be so kind as to give us the- ah, what were they called again?" For once, I'm at a loss for words. I eyeball

Bael questioningly, and his brain works out the correct answer, surprisingly enough.

"Passwords, Third. We need the passwords."

"Right, that was it." I gently reach over and rest my hand on the female's shoulder. "Give us the passwords to your computer systems, and I won't burn each of your limbs off one by one. I'll give you a merciful, quick death, just like your comrades."

The woman starts to nod her head, but before she can say anything, the man sticks his blaster in her ribcage and pulls the trigger, melting her heart instantly. I *don't* mean that in a romantic sense.

She flops to the ground, and the life fades from her eyes. "Quick thinking, meatbag." Bael snickers. "Keh keh, she was about to crack, too."

"Indeed. How very annoying. Now, all we have left is one strong-willed human, and it would be a waste of time trying to break him."

"I'm not a meatbag. My name is Benjamin Brown. I won't surrender to the likes of you. If you want passwords, it's the last thing you will get."

He starts to raise the weapon to his head, but Bael lashes forward with his lightning fast palm-strike and batters Benjamin's arm, sending the gun flying.

"Aaahhh!" The man screams in agony and falls to his knees, and even I grimace a little bit. His arm is bent awkwardly behind himself, not a pleasant sight for sure.

"That was a little much, First. Now we have one less limb to torture him with." Before Bael can say anything, I shrug. "Ah, never mind. Too much trouble. Let's just kill him. We'll have to make do without the passwords."

A sound of glass shattering in the other room makes all three of us look at the room's doorway in surprise. Screams of my demonic Royal Guard can be heard, along with the sound of something akin to wet rags being tossed in a pile, and the *thud* of bodies smashing into the wall.

I'm quite surprised when from around the corner, the body of a young woman emerges. She's covered in blood, likely from my guards she just killed, and yet I sense the same lack of energy that all humans have. She doesn't even have a weapon. How did she-

Oh, I see. She's that slave-girl Jason took under his wing. Larry, was it? Humans have such undistinguished guttural names, they all sound the same to me.

She looks flabbergasted. "Where's Jason? I thought he was here!"

Ben, still trying not to pass out from the pain, looks over at her weakly. "Lora...? You shouldn't- you're too late. Everyone is dead."

"I know." She points at Bael and I. "I loathe demons. Before I leave, I'll take out the both of you."

First glances back at me. "Say, didn't Jason enhance this female to be tougher than others of her kind? She's all muscles, right?"

"Indeed. Are you going to have a swing at her?"

Bael cracks his neck and turns to face her. "I need a workout. I'll snap her in half, and after I'm done, I'll have a little fun with whatever's left."

"You repugnant oaf. Have at her then. See if I care." I roll my eyes in disgust.

He's so uncivilized.

Bael ignores my insult and advances toward the young woman, his head scraping across the ceiling as he walks. His massive figure dwarfs her, like a mountain compared to a molehill. "Ya know, sweetie, we killed all your little friends. Yama said that since we didn't need the whores anymore, they were useless. I didn't have much fun killin' meatbags that couldn't fight back, but you seem different. Hit me real good."

I can barely see her face from behind Bael's bulk, but the sensation of anger and rage is unmistakable in the air. "You- you bastard! I'll tear you apart!"

She charges at him, hurling a table in the process, but all I can do is yawn.

It doesn't matter how strong she is. Nobody can beat Bael when it comes to a physical bout. I could easily defeat him during a no-holds-barred fight, but I'm just not interested in wasting my time.

Their blows collide, and I turn back to Ben. "I wonder if I should keep you as a pet?"

* * *

Thousands? No. Millions.

Angels keep spawning at a ludicrous rate. Like a stream that has transformed into a raging river, humans die and appear in the air, falling to the ground in ever increasing numbers. In all my eons of living, I've never seen a sight like this. Using my spiritual energy, it's all I can do just to shove the mass of half-breeds below to the side to unblock the area where the new ones are appearing. Should I fail to keep it clear, they will likely pile up and start fusing together, then die horrific deaths. It is not a sight I wish to see.

Zarall, not one to use his powers regularly, pants with exhaustion as he tries to help me shove new angels out of the way. Other purebloods are working to put down the prison insurrection, but the prisoner numbers have been rapidly deflated by the arrival of unrelated

humans. It took us a while to figure out a Volgrim invasion of human space was the cause for this, but now that we know, the unending torrent of new arrivals makes sense. It's the worst case scenario. If we survive this, the energy ration will be greatly diminished, and potentially even inverse.

The angels will begin to die off, short of us taking drastic action to protect ourselves.

"Gabriel, how much- how much longer?" Zarall wheezes after shoving another small pile to the side, each new arrival staring around in bewilderment at what's going on.

"I don't know, brother. Take a break; I'll keep up the work."

He nods and falls backward, collapsing softly on his wings, and breathes hard. "Thuh-thank you. I'm sorry for my weakness, Gabriel."

"Gabriel! Zarall!" A voice cries out from my left, the direction of the palace, and I breathe a little easier as Raphael and Zeus fly over to us. Raphael lands first. "I brought the King. What is the situation?"

I explain hurriedly, and Zeus gnashes his teeth. "I can't believe it. The Volgrim! And after all their talk of negotiations..."

Raphael nods sagely. "It is no wonder they wished to build a portal to Heaven. In any case, we cannot leave Humanity as they are. This situation is also quite dire for us."

Zeus stares at the fountain of pseudo-angels pouring from the distant sky. "We may need to purge them. They are going to drain our reserves."

Raphael coughs, "My liege, we have more than enough energy to survive a long time after this war is over, and vast stores of energy saved up for situations such as this. I would advise we assist the humans in their hour of need."

Zarall jumps to his feet, his tiredness gone. "There is another solution! Send these half-breeds to the front lines! They were human before, so fighting for their previous species might be a good maneuver, and if they die, it's less of a burden on our energy supply."

All four of us nod in unison. Zeus pats me on the shoulder. "A wise choice, but we need to get these recruits back to Earth. What if-"

He's interrupted by an angel flying forth, a pseudo-angel, by the looks of him. "You there! You are King Zeus, as well as the Archangels, correct?" When we nod, he sighs in relief. "My name is General Zhao. Jason Hiro slaughtered all of humanity's top military leaders at once. We suspect he is in league with the demons, and this may be part of a broad, concerted effort to mix with the Volgrim and bring humanity to its knees."

Zhao explains quickly to us the events that transpired, and Raphael's face pales. "I... I can't believe it. Magical powers? But he's a human! He-"

Raphael stops suddenly and turns to look me in the eye. "You're thinking it too, aren't you? This must be related to what we discussed recently."

"Yes, you're probably right. Jason Hiro is the key. We have to find him." I nod at Raphael, before turning to Zeus. "We first need to aid the humans. If all of their leadership has been killed, then we will send the leaders back first. I recommend opening a portal directly to Earth. That will speed up transit times exponentially."

Zeus looks uneasy. "I agree with the sentiment, but putting a portal there, while they are under attack, is directly opening us to our own invasion. The Volgrim currently only have one way here, and that way is through the Lirius system where our warp gate resides. It may only be a hundred light-years from Earth, but that's still close enough for them to jump to and invade us within a few hours, or less if they're using Trifrancium to jump at ultra-high warp speeds."

Zeus pauses to glance at the human converts still spawning in, before frowning. "Actually, I've just changed my mind. Gabriel, take this small amount of energy, make a portal to Earth, and we'll destroy it if the situation becomes dangerous for our kind."

Well, at least he convinced himself. "Yes, my King. I will make the most of this opportunity."

Raphael shakes his head. "I remember when the amount of energy needed to make a new Gate would have nearly exhausted our energy. Times have changed, haven't they, Zeus?"

Zeus's expression has a hard-set edge to it. "Indeed, they have."

* * *

My head won't stop pounding. I can't feel my arms or my legs, and my vision is out of the question. I can only use my telekinesis to feel around, like a false set of limbs, and a newly acquired sense... the ability to 'see' the energy of those around me.

They look *delicious*.

Small blips of energy scatter as I hover through the hallways, heading nowhere in particular. Each blue light, seen through a filter of darkness, is snuffed out and swallowed as I continue to drain the energy of anyone in my way. Each drop of energy lessens the pain in my skull, but the agony always returns a minute later.

I need more energy. GIVE IT TO ME! I am the Supreme Commander, and the energy of worthless parasites is mine to take!

I bump into a wall and frown. I can usually detect them with my telekinesis, but this one- ah, it's been partially destroyed. My false 'arms' must have passed right through it.

I can hear explosions in the distance. I feel a trembling in the air sometimes, but I don't know what the cause is. Fighting? Who? Why?

I'm blind, but not deaf. I can hear a squeak of fright as I draw near. A woman's voice. "No... please!"

Everyone begs me to stop, but I don't care what their complaints are. She falls to the ground, comatose, once I've had my fill.

Perhaps if they hadn't stood up to me, perhaps if they had treated me with the respect I deserve, it wouldn't have had to happen like this.

But *no*, instead they tried to assassinate me. This is how I'm repaid, in the end, for my mercy to humankind.

I will never forget how they turned on me.

There's nobody left on this floor or fifty floors above. I smash my way through the ground below and float down to the next level, where once again delicious drops of energy scatter and scream. One stops in front of me, and I perceive him or her lift their arms up, probably to aim a gun at me, but I don't let those types live. His energy is drained and body destroyed summarily, and I move on to the next morsels.

This is the freest I've ever felt in my whole life. No more people talking back to me, no more plots and plans, deviations and ploys, just people terrified of my awe-inspiring power.

It should always have been like this. I was a fool to play the good guy. I can't change the universe unless I bend it to my will. And even if I do make a difference, who cares? It's much more important to enjoy myself. The opinions of an insect mean nothing to a God.

"Jason Hiro! Enemy of the state! Stop right there!"

A voice yells out, and I can hear footsteps, but I can't sense the energy of the one talking.

He continues. "You are under arrest for plotting with the demons to take over humanity! Do not resist, or we will use lethal force!"

Heh. 'Lethal force', he says. He must have anti-energy surrounding him, that's why I can't sense him. No matter.

" Collapse. "

With a single word, the sides of the building give out all at once. I teleport away to the world outside this tower and listen in satisfaction as the building crumbles down, pulverizing each floor with the one above it.

Hovering in midair, the sound of one of Humanity's greatest building accomplishments falling to pieces thanks to a single word fills me with joy. I have the power to rule the universe. None can oppose me.

Squandering this gift would be foolish.

I teleport inside another Stratoscraper nearby and resume my work, but something isn't right. This one is usually filled with people too, but all around me, the energy within their bodies is weak.

"S-Supreme... Commander..." A man's voice whispers from just a few feet away. "Save us... the demons... they..."

His voice trails off and a final hiss of air escapes his mouth. What's this about demons? Is Yama up to something?

"Human!" A different voice, much further away, sounds off. "It's the Supreme Commander!"

His energy comes into view, and it's much different from all the humans I've seen so far. Red and twisted, like a roaring flame, it is far more concentrated than that of the skimpy portions I've had until now.

Many other balls of red energy come into view, likely from around walls and corners. The sight of them is making me weak with hunger. " **Bow.** "

"Huh?" Confusion is in their voices, but the sounds of their knees hitting the floor and their figures prostrating themselves before me makes me happier than I ever thought I could be. *Lunch-time.*

A few moments later, my power has increased more than ever, since just a dozen demons had more energy than all the humans up to this point.

And when I think about things in that way, I've been going about this incorrectly the whole time! Forget humans; I should be focusing on angels and demons!

There's a shift in the air. When I look towards its source, I can only gasp. Four sources of energy appear, two of them are large enough to put all these demons to shame, but one of them is insanely bright, like looking directly at the sun. I have to turn away from it, for fear of blinding myself.

"There you are. We've come to stop you, once and for all, *Hope.* "

The voice that speaks... it's... my voice?

Suddenly I'm on the alert. It's another Jason, just like the one I defeated before. But this one is stupendously powerful. His energy might just be enough to shred the universe to pieces. I

don't have a moment to waste. An ambush is the only way to win.

" **Create!** " A hardened, ultra-dense pebble appears in the air before me, hovering with aid from my telekinesis. " **FIRE!!** "

My eardrums are nearly blown out as a stupendously powerful explosion smashes me backward, pounding me through god knows what furniture and other things are in the room, and the pebble rockets forward, smashing into the other Jason and-

"That won't work." His voice speaks again, and the sound of a weak *thud* echoes across the room. "I knew you were a monster. But this? Now you've gone too far, Hope. You can't even pick an ally. You just devour the demons and the humans alike for your own selfish greed."

What the hell is he talking about? Why does he keep calling me Hope?

"My name is Jason Hiro. I can't see you, but your voice is the same as mine. I suppose you're another one of Marie's clones, eh?"

I pull myself back up to a floating position, and the other Jason pauses. "You must be lying. Of course you're Hope. Who do you think you're fooling? Your actions speak louder than words."

The smaller energy signature takes a step forward. "Hold on; maybe he isn't lying. Perhaps he doesn't remember yet." His voice is also the same as mine!? Two Jasons?! How am I supposed to fight two of them? And what of the smaller energy signatures, are they also me?! Four?!

"You have a point. Let us see if he is lying then. **Remember.** "

* * *

I can't think- oh god- so many memories... so many! AHHHH!

A tornado, a hurricane in my head! My brain already hurts enough! MAKE IT STOP!

* * *

I collapse to the floor, an eternity having passed.

I remember now.

I remember everything.

"Hero. That's who you are." I speak to the Jason before me.

His voice is tinged with smugness. "So now you know, eh? We've come to put an end to you, Hope. You're done for."

Ha...

Haha...

Hahahaha!!

HAAAAAAAAHAHAHA!!!

He has the wrong person.

"I'm not Hope. But I know who is."

Chapter 3 – Route C

Part 427c: Doubt

A few dozen demons chatter amongst one another, sitting at tables here and there. The stale air in the room fills my nostrils, my disgust only matched by a silent apprehension regarding the conclusion of this game.

Clink, clink, clang.

The Eldest Animus, Smealum, tosses his bones onto the demon-stone table and they spill around into various shapes, followed immediately by the stone-carved Mahja sticks.

"Heh. The Hydra pattern, with four flames. Luck is on my side today." Smealum chuckles to himself before rubbing his bronzed arm. "You'll have a tough time beating that, eh, Ylvusk?"

He's right. The Hydra pattern is a challenge to roll and only occurs once in a thousand tosses. I glare snidely at the Animus. "Cheatin', are ya? And here I thought High Demons were respectable."

A Demon Duke sitting at our small table snickers to himself. "You're an idiot. Smealum just has the wrist movement perfected."

"I don't need you to defend me, Torlok." Smealum beckons at me. "Anything can happen in a game of Sticks and Bones. Your toss, Ylvusk. Unless you haven't got what it takes?"

The sound of embers crackling from a nearby torch fills me with unease. "This is just a friendly game, right?"

"Of course. We wouldn't want to bully a lowly dark-walker." Smealum's snickers quietly to himself.

A couple of other demons at a nearby table peer at us with interest, whispering something about Smealum's Hydra toss, but I can't make their words out. Smealum and Torlok both smile at each other, even though Torlok tossed a Salamander when it was his turn. *Hardly worth bragging about*, I think to myself.

I scoop the dried bones up, filling my right hand, handling them gingerly so I won't break them. The dealer here is known for his temper when imps break his pieces, and I had to pay the rental fee today. *Cheap-ass High Demons*. I grab the Mahja sticks with my left hand, holding all five with the eyeball patterns facing me. There are four sides to each rectangular stick, but somehow I feel the eyes are the luckiest. Other demons swear by the flames, and maybe even the fists, but nobody likes the sword. The sword is simply too... *human*.

An instant later, I flick my right hand out, and the bones scatter across the table. My heart skips a beat. *Basilisk!* Just one point less than a Hydra!

Next are the Mahja sticks. They clatter heavily against the demon-stone and immediately dash my hopes against the rocks.

Torlok laughs heartily. "Bwahaha! Two swords and a full spread! Pathetic! My lowest underling could do better!"

The Eldest Animus leans back in his seat and stretches mightily. "Looks like it's 7-6-6, my favor. Too bad though, I preferred the score from last round."

The other demons in the room sigh and go back to talking or whatever they were doing. Several long moments pass as boredom creeps into all three of our minds, and finally Torlok coughs into his fist. "Say, Ylvusk, you've had this miserable feeling about ya all day long. Anything going on?"

As Smealum watches silently, all I can do is sigh. "Yeah, kinda. Tvoorik's evaluation is today. He's been nervous, given that evolutions are so rare lately."

"Mutations." The Animus corrects me with a single word. "Still, it's nice to hear the Emperors are even considering him. Energy for mutations is scarce these days. We've been losing demons left and right to the humans..." Smealum's voice catches slightly. "I guess that's part of life."

Interestingly, even Torlok is a little downcast. "You're lucky you've got such a good friend, Ylvusk. Tvoorik can be a bit precocious, but he's intelligent. For a demon."

Smealum finishes that thought. "Torlok and I had such a friend, once. The humans took him away from us."

Torlok exhales angrily. "Not *humans*. One human. *Hero*. That mangy little meatbag, barely even out of 'is capsule thing, and he kills Yama with one word. Just one! I swear, if I ever get my hands on him..."

A murmuring goes around the room as several other demons look at our table, then back to each other. Most of them nod and mumble in agreement with each other. One demon with a terrible scar across his face speaks out. "I was with the Duke of Reptiles not long back. The humans came from nowhere, wiped out a whole squad of orcs in the blink of an eye! I barely made it out alive! Filthy meatbags, they wouldn't be nothin' without that Hero among them!"

I slink into my chair slightly. *Oops. Tvoorik and I were there for that. I hope this scarred one doesn't recognize me.*

Several other demons pound their tables angrily and start whooping, demanding the blood of the humans, but Smealum raises his hand. "Now now, calm down. That's an order. We won't defeat the humans by stooping to their level of barbarity. I've seen the humans fight our people, long ago, in the time before many of you were born. It's best to leave matters of war to the Demon Emperors. They know how to deal with humans."

From across the room, a familiar voice speaks up. "Oh, *do they?*" I sit up a little straighter and look over to see my bestest buddy in the whole Labyrinth, Tvoorik, ambling towards our table. "Last I checked, the Demon Emperors are in charge right now, and we're still losing demons by the thousands every month!"

I catch a look of annoyance from Smealum as he turns away from Tvoorik. *Oh brother, not this kook*, his eyes say.

Tvoorik strides over and sits down to my right, then nudges me in the shoulder. "They denied me!"

"Huh? They refused your mutation?" My feeling of happiness vanishes. "That stinks like rats! You've been working hard for demonkind!"

Tvoorik winks at me before turning his dual-horned head to Smealum. "Didn't I tell you? If I mutate into an Oracle, I'll know too much. They're scared of me putting all the pieces together!"

"Uh huh." Smealum is wholly unconvinced, and he shifts his chair slightly further from Tvoorik. "If you say so."

"I do, I do!" Tvoorik nods excitedly. "Think about it! This one human shows up outta nowhere, blows up two planets, unites all of humanity, and starts killing demons by the thousands, and the Emperors just *let him* get away with it? They're *in on it!*"

"Right, right, an inside job. Of course." Smealum rolls his eyes dramatically and looks away from the table. "What do the Emperors have to gain by the killing of our kind, anyway? Your theories always seem to hand-wave that part away."

Tvoorik's black eyes, those of a shadow-walker, shine for a moment. "It's so obvious! With fewer demons around, the Emperors can scoop up more energy for themselves! If the humans stage a comeback, they can also order more of the lower-ranked demons to their deaths against the humans, and thus cull the undesirables who speak out against their tyranny!"

"Such as yourself?" Smealum coughs the words out, but Tvoorik ignores him.

I tap my lip thoughtfully as he rants. "Isn't it possible the Hero is as strong as everyone says? Even Mephisto lost to him..."

This time, it's Torlok who chimes in. "Mephisto ain't a big deal. His whole thing is being a ghost, and nobody can land a hit on him. If the Hero were able to get around that, Mephisto would be a cakewalk."

Smealum grabs a Mahja stick and rolls it around in his hand absentmindedly as he stares at Tvoorik. "Only a stupid demon would deny the existence of heroes. We might not have witnessed their power in tens of millions of years, but I assure you, they exist." His eyes narrow and he glances at the bones on the table. After a few moments, he pokes them around, until he forms the Dragon shape. "The curious thing is that I can't remember anything about the last Hero. The fleshbag existed, but I remember nothing. We don't even have records of his or her power. Curious."

Torlok points a wrinkled finger at one of the lower ranked demons. "You, gimme a Blood Pie." He turns back to Tvoorik, "Smealum's right. We both saw the power of the Hero, but neither of us remembers the fella. If you wanna talk about conspiracies, there ya go."

My best friend's eyes light up at the thought. "I'm telling you! The hero's working with the top demons! It's a plot to keep us in line! Things were going too easy, so he let loose the Black Witch! If you line up the dots, everything makes perfect sense."

"That's the thing about conspiracies," Smealum drawls, "they always fit together so conveniently."

Tvoorik groans, but sits in silence for a long minute before nudging the Mahja stick. "There's no winning with you. Look, let's just play some Sticks and Bones and worry about it later."

Torlok licks his lips as the underling demon brings over his Blood Pie. "You imps play a few rounds without me. I'm starving."

"You're such a pig, Torlok." Smealum grabs the bones and sticks and shakes them around. "I'll make this round exciting. The losers each have to hunt five humans for the winner."

I glare into Tvoorik's dark eyes before turning to Smealum. "Two-to-one odds, both of us versus you. We're gonna cream ya."

"It's your pyre," Smealum says as he gives the bones a toss.

* * *

" *Everything is your fault. You trusted him.* "

Cassiel's voice speaks, but her mouth doesn't move. Her head leans back against my hand, and the sight of her wrenched neck causes my chest to tighten.

" *Our deaths are on your hands. You betrayed us.* "

Blood pools from the gash in Samantha's chest and runs down my arm. I can barely keep a grip on her, and she begins to slip away.

"I- I didn't mean to! It was an accident! What else could I have done?!"

Their eyes close, and two final words fall from Cassiel's lips. " *-your fault...* "

GUH!

The strange fog vanishes and my breathing speeds up, soon the girls vanish and my eyes open. There's a wood ceiling above me, curving up to a triangular roof. My breath comes in ragged gasps, and soon I blink away the strange delirium.

The sound of a strange empty wind batters our small wooden house. The cute sound of Cassiel's almost silent snoring to my right, and Samantha mumbling in her sleep to my left makes the tightness in my chest loosen. Silently, I rub both of their backs and press the girls against me.

It was just a dream. A nightmare, even. *It felt so real.*

Where am I? What am I doing, again? Ah, right. I remember now. We're on that strange barren planet. Another bubble-world to explore. Just a night of sleep before we set out on an adventure.

Somehow, this moment, the feeling of the girls on each side of me, and the smell of oddly sanitized air- it's all familiar. Deja Vu.

I shake my head to clear the muddled feeling in my brain, then gingerly pull myself up to a sitting position, carefully extracting Cassiel's wing from under me. I wouldn't want to yank a fluffy feather out accidentally.

After I've righted myself, I glance around the room. There is only one window to the outside world, but it shows a barren brown dustbowl. Before I purified the air of this planet, it was acrid and nearly impossible to breathe in. I don't know why the Labyrinth would connect to this world. I have yet to understand many things about demons and their goals. Why did they enslave humans, yet never kill us? Why allow people to live normally inside of bubble worlds just like this one?

Samantha shifts around next to me, and I use the opportunity to teleport out of bed and into our small kitchen. Quietly, I wordsmith just under my breath. " **Juice.** "

A glass of cherry lemonade pops into existence in front of me, and I silently sip it down while I gaze through the lone window. There are mountains in the distance and huge cracks and fissures in the land before them, but every few moments, I feel as if something is calling to me.

Sometimes it's a sweet whisper, begging me to come closer, other times a nagging sensation, as if I *must* go forth.

"Hero? You're awake?" I'm startled and flinch as the ever-sneaky Samantha slinks up to my side, yawns, and presses herself against me.

"Yup." I wrap my free arm around her to steady my nerves. I'm not this jumpy usually. Keeping my voice quiet to not wake up Cassiel, I continue. "I had a hell of a dream last night. More of a nightmare, honestly."

"Mmm." She snaps her hand forward and snatches the lemonade out of my hand, downing the remainder in one gulp, before poking me in the spine with her pointy tail. "Did the big strong man get scared by a bad dream?"

"It's hard to explain." I resist smiling as she teases me, since I'm being serious for once. "I don't remember what it was about, but it was awful. I never want to feel that way again."

Her smile fades away. "Oh, love. You want me to kiss the pain away?"

I pull away from her and walk over to the mini-bedroom, then pull on my underwear and pants. "Not right now. Let's just wake up Cassiel in a little while and get going, Belial."

Samantha pauses to stare at me in surprise, and at that moment, I feel Deja Vu once again. "How do you know that's my name?"

"Uhh..." I trail off as I look her in the eyes. "I don't know. Didn't you tell me?"

"No." She shakes her head. "I wasn't planning to tell you unless I had to. I'm not mad, you know, but that name- it isn't me. It belongs to the second demon emperor, and I loathe that title."

"I know." Pulling my shirt on, I murmur and glance at the dried desert outside the window. "Something feels very familiar about today."

Samantha slips over and sits in my lap, and the two of us hold each other for a long few minutes. Saying nothing, but enjoying each other's company, and eventually the sound of rustling on the bed makes us look back. Cassiel yawns and opens her eyes to stare at us. "Oh, I see you're both having a great time."

"Something like that."

* * *

Cassiel and Samantha walk on either side of me as the hot wind blows against us. Cassiel's magical barrier extends from out of her body and surrounds all three of us quite comfortably,

protecting us from the worst of the elements, but still, the massive star in the sky beats down savagely on the plantless desert.

"I hope we aren't here too long. This world is unbearable." Cassiel complains loudly, and everyone nods in agreement.

"It wasn't always this way." Samantha, in a rare moment of insight, speaks as if she's been here before. "Sometimes these worlds have quite a rich history."

A single small rock bounces across the desert, passing us and rolling away to an unknown destination, far behind us.

"Have you been here before?" I direct the question at Samantha, but Cassiel shoves her white hair out of her mouth and decides I must have been asking her.

"It's my first time."

"Oh. I was actually, ah, asking Samantha." I correct her quickly. Cassiel looks a little miffed but shrugs and looks away.

Samantha leans her head against my arm. "I may have been here once or twice. Why do you ask?"

"Do you know what this planet's name is? It's already far bigger than any other we've come across until now."

The succubus pretends to ponder it for a few moments before shaking her head. "Not a clue, love. I'm awful with names and faces. I certainly can't remember the name of some random bubble world."

Bubble world. That's the term I've used to describe portals to other worlds within the Labyrinth. I never thought too hard about the term, but I started calling them that because of Hero City. Without a doubt, it was a legitimate planet, albeit impossibly small. I could walk around the entire globe in just a few hours, and the city spun around into the horizon at an eye-rubbingly short distance. Other than Hero City, I've encountered only a few other small planets, though none at quite the same tiny scale.

And this planet? It must be the size of Earth. Somehow, when I look past the desolate wastes, I see a place that once teemed with life.

"That's fine. No need to dwell on- AGH!" A terrible ringing sensation explodes in the back of my head, like a distant screeching sound. The tattoos on my darkened skin pulse with magical energy, as if something is agitating them. Immediately, a feeling of fear washes over me, as I trace the location to a crater several miles away.

I know what's in that crater. The thoughts in my head swirl around like a raging volcano. An image of a an inhuman expression flashes in my mind, as though a memory from a distant past had somehow infiltrated my psyche.

"Are you okay, Hero?" Cassiel's voice brings me back to full alertness, and the painful ringing fades away. She tilts forward to look up at my face. "Your face is ashen."

"Sorry. There's a buzzing sensation in the back of my head. It's like a beacon of some sort, and it's pointing me in that direction." I point towards the crater a few miles away, and Samantha inhales sharply.

"A buzzing sensation? I don't feel anything. You're not imagining it, right?" Samantha glares at the crater in the distance.

"Absolutely not. Let's be cautious."

An hour passes as we shuffle through the desert, but we pick up the speed as we move closer and closer to the crater. When we finally reach the lip of the crater, my chest is heaving. That goddamn buzzing has become more akin to a foghorn, and I can scarcely keep on my feet.

Once I spot the spaceship below, I know for a fact that I've seen it before. It shouldn't be possible, but I've stood at the lip of this crater once already. I just don't know *when*.

Cassiel leers over the edge and the steep incline half a mile to the ship below. "I'll fly you down there."

"That- ah... that won't be necessary." I groan as another headache sprouts inside of the previous one. The spaceship must be hitting me with radiation or something because the feeling is unbearable. Without waiting to give her an explanation, I teleport down below and pound on the ship's exterior with my knuckle. Instantly, the buzzing ceases. *Just as I knew it would.*

With the pain gone, I quickly examine it. *Galaxy Exploration Force*, read the faded letters on the side. Several characters are worn off, but a few are barely visible. The ship is the length of a football field and shaped like an hourglass. Its large rear section of the ship has dozens of engines facing backward, while a somewhat narrower middle section connects to the bulbous front of the ship. Windows are smashed all over the outside of the ship, and the general condition of it is bad enough that I have to assume the crash landing was unbelievably violent.

Walking around the front of the ship, I spot what is probably the bridge, and I'm surprised to see it's built for only four crew members. On a ship this size, one would think they'd need a dozen people to manage everything.

They probably have robots to help out, I think to myself as I step inside. Two inches of dust coats every surface and wall, and I immediately sneeze twice as I look around. Thanks to this

planet's sun, the inside of the Bridge is somewhat illuminated, but the hallway that leads deeper into the ship is dark and foreboding. Focusing my energy on the tattoos covering my body, I force them to glow brighter than ever, turning myself into a lightbulb that illuminates the room around me.

The bridge is covered in futuristic-looking LCD-panels, but all of them are long since broken and useless. Tapping the nearest one does nothing.

Walking over to the half-open door, I put my back into it and start to yank it open, only for the door to hiss loudly and pop open easily. The ship appears to still have power.

Indeed, a popping sound above alerts me to lights flickering on, and a few moments later, the tattoos on my body have served their purpose. The lights above are dim and covered in dust, but they do an adequate job illuminating the corridor before me. With the lights now on, I spot several skeletons, with scraps of clothing still attached. Humans, probably, and long since dead. If I had to guess, I'd say most of them were... American? It's tough to say.

A movement further up the hallway makes me stiffen. A man appears and turns to look directly at me. I recognize him in an instant as he speaks. "Greeting: Hello, I am glad to serve you! Hello, I am glad to serve you!"

I clear my throat and make sure to keep my distance. "You are... OMEN, correct?"

Part 428c: Return To The Ship

The rubber-skinned automaton stares at me vacuously, as though I'm little more than a blank blackboard for him to etch chalk onto. The sound of wind batters the shell of the spacecraft, but I can only slightly hear it through all the metal insulation.

"Pleasant Answer: Yes, you are correct. I am the Original Mechanical Exploratory Neohuman. My shortened designation is OMEN Unit 17. Question: What is your designation?" A fake smile plasters itself across OMEN's face, and I shudder slightly. Without a doubt, I've seen that expression before, and something about it chills my blood.

I look past the robot, at the barely illuminated corridor that leads to a sealed off door in the back. "My designation is, well, Hero, I suppose. My real name is Jason Hiro, but nobody calls me that."

OMEN closes his eyes for a moment before opening them again. "Processing. Response: Jason Hiro, it is my pleasure to serve you. My memory files are very corrupted due to this craft running in a low-power state for so long. What is the situation on Mars?"

"Mars?" I stare at him in surprise. "Why would you ask about Mars?"

The robot tilts his head slightly. "Thoughtful Elaboration: Mars is the fourth planet in the Terran-Sol system. As per the obliteration of Earth via the Volgrim's surprise attack, Mars is the new homeworld for humanity in Earth's absence." OMEN pauses for a moment, "Unsubstantiated Hypothesis: Due to sustained lack of contact with the homeworld, it is possible that the Volgrim may have eradicated humanity. Revised Query: What is the status on the whole of humanity itself? Are you the last remaining survivor?"

I take a few moments to respond. My head is swimming with the implications of everything OMEN just said. "I, uh- well, that is..."

Thoughtfully, I lower my head to stare at the floor and tap my lips. *Don't tell him there are other humans left!* My mind screams a warning to me. Once again, that funny feeling that I've done this before itches at the back of my skull.

I quickly lift my head back up and stare right into OMEN's soulless eyes. "The majority of humanity has been wiped out. I lead the final resistance against the demonic hordes."

OMEN doesn't hesitate. "Response Analyzed: Your reply indicates you are now the highest ranked member of the United Earth Federation. Rapid Query: Is this analysis correct?"

"Yes."

OMEN nods in response. "Authorization Confirmed: Pending any further developments, I have registered you as the proxy Supreme Commander of the United Earth Federation. Random Query: How were you able to locate this ship's distress signal without a transponder?"

A transponder? I don't even know what that is. "Well, I came here because I felt this awful buzzing in the back of my head. As I walked closer, it became almost unbearable, but I pounded on the ship's hull, and that stopped it."

OMEN takes several long moments to respond, before slowly closing and opening his eyes. "Cautious Presumption: You are a Candidate. Query: *Are you a Candidate?*"

I don't know what a Candidate is, but that strange feeling nags at me once again. "Um. Yes."

OMEN's internals release an odd grinding sound, and a moment later he attempts to bow, but his rusted frame creaks under the effort. "Error: Unable to provide correct body motion to show deference. Bypassing. If you are a Candidate, then this OMEN unit will remove all red-level data lockdowns. Do you have any queries of your own?"

This robot... he speaks so oddly, yet once I look past my initial misgivings, he isn't all that bad. He might even be useful. "A few. How long has this ship been stranded here?"

He pauses. "Tentative Response: Data corruption renders this unit's answer inconclusive, but a preliminary estimate puts the crash data for this ship at approximately one hundred million, two hundred thousand, five hundred forty-five years, nine months, seventeen days, and-"

I cut him off before he can finish. "Right, I get the idea. What happened to the crew?"

"Detailed Response: Immediately following the crash, the toxic atmosphere of Volgarius Alpha spread throughout the ship. Any personnel not equipped with exploration suits died in minutes. Unfortunately, the GEF-140 was only equipped with five such suits." OMEN emotionlessly describes the events of that day, then shakes his head. "Due to the hostile atmosphere of this planet, and the limited oxygen the five officers were able to salvage, they were barely able to survive for five months while they waited for rescue. All personnel perished waiting for a response."

"Oh. I'm sorry. I don't know what to say." I cough into my hand. "Apologies for all the questions... but why did you crash here?"

OMEN tilts his head down to look at a blank display before him. "Error: My memory archives are incomplete regarding that matter. Data degradation is substantial."

Gingerly, I walk past him and peek into a side-room where more ancient bones are lying on the floor. "Why were you-" I pause for a moment. "Wait, did you say this planet's name is

Volgarius Alpha?"

"Affirmative. It is the former homeworld of humanity's greatest enemy, the Volgrim."

The Volgrim. OMEN mentioned them before, but I wasn't paying much attention. "Who, or what, are Volgrim?"

"Elaboration: The scourge of the Milky Way. They are an alien species that launched an unjustified war on humanity, and eventually, they rendered Earth uninhabitable via their highly advanced weaponry." OMEN creaks as he lifts up one of his arms and a holographic projection of a face appears in midair, beaming from a projector in his palm, though it's very distorted and difficult to see. "Their forms are quite similar to those of a humans', other than their six-fingered hands and reptilian-like mouths filled to the brim with razor-sharp teeth. Despite their similarities to humans, Volgrim act very differently and are regarded as the most dangerous threat humanity has ever faced."

"I see. They do sound scary... but why was your ship scouting out their former homeworld?"

OMEN takes my question in stride. "Hypothesis: Though this unit cannot know the exact details behind any orders given out from Humanity's leaders, it is hypothesized they wished to learn more regarding the homeworld of their greatest enemy, to find potentially damaging secrets that could lead to total annihilation of the Volgrim."

Tapping my foot thoughtfully, I pivot quickly to my last question. "How did this ship maintain power for a hundred million years? Even in a low-power state, that seems rather ludicrous."

"Proud Response: After the biological crew perished, the synthetics aboard reconfigured the ship to draw power from the toxic particles in the atmosphere. At a concentration of twelve percent, Diolithinitroxicine proved an adequate substitute for other materials to power the ship's engines. Additionally, the lower concentration of oxygen in the atmosphere, while detrimental to biological life, has alleviated issues with corrosion for the synthetic crew. Every five years, I would reactivate the ship, and we would repair any severely damaged systems as best as we could. We have functioned remarkably well given the circumstances."

Almost immediately, the robot's fake smiles vanishes and a more neutral expression replaces it. "Observation: Until twenty-nine hours and thirteen minutes ago, this planet's atmosphere had remained relatively stable. It suddenly shifted to something more akin to what a biological life form, especially a human, would find ideal. Query: Are you the cause of this change?"

I nod slowly, unsure if this will piss OMEN off. "Yes... I changed the atmosphere myself."

My body flinches reflexively as a panel in the ceiling suddenly slides open, and a tiny camera-like device pops out and aims at me. Two seconds later, OMEN returns to his generic creepy smile. "Examination Complete: Scans indicate an exceedingly high level of spiritual energy. As expected of a Candidate. Additionally, this unit has detected two other biologicals just outside the vessel, and each of them also has a large amount of spiritual energy. Hypothesis: They are hostile entities. Request: Permission to eliminate?"

My body stiffens almost immediately. "Denied. They're with me."

"Noted: Reconfiguring analysis. Each entity has been scanned and filed as allied life forms. Do you have any other commands?"

I rub the back of my head thoughtfully. "You're, uh, cool with me having magical energy, then? Right? You're not going to try and kill me or anything?"

OMEN stares at me silently for a moment, as if I'm stupid. "Amused Response: No. As a Candidate leading humanity, you are expected to have magical abilities. That much is evident."

Oh. *This smug piece of shit...*

"Yeah, okay. I'll be right back. I need to grab Cassiel and Samantha. They're probably annoyed I'm taking so long."

OMEN nods, perhaps a little too dramatically. "Acknowledgement: Acknowledged! I will wait for you to return. Should I keep this ship in low-power mode?"

A sigh escapes my lips. "Seriously, dude. I'll be back in a minute. Calm your tits."

* * *

Cassiel is tapping her foot impatiently and crossing her arms with a cute pouty expression, but the look on Samantha's face is one of dread. As I walk over the hill to where they're standing, Samantha exhales deeply. "Oh, good. You're back. I was worried."

The angel rolls her eyes. "Sammy, you're such a kid! Ooh, ooh! Hero, what's down there? Was there anything cool?"

I smile, but it feels a little insincere given all the information OMEN just dumped on me. I'm not certain how to cope with what he told me, nor how to piece together a missing history I know nothing about. "Sorta. The ship still has power, unbelievably enough. I found a robot inside, and he filled me in on a bunch of information. Wanna come down and have a look?"

Cassiel nearly jumps into my arms in excitement. "Do I ever!"

Samantha is far more reserved. She turns to look out at the horizon, "I'd, ah, rather not. I don't like technology. Human weapons are distressing."

Her concern worries me. Despite Cassiel's excitement and how she's tugging at my shirt, I wave her off. "Hold on, Cassiel. Samantha, I'll protect you. The ship has recognized me as the leader of humanity, and it registered both of you as my allies. It won't hurt you."

She shakes her head and digs a heel in the ground. "I don't want to, Jason. It's not even about fear for me. Machines make me... uncomfortable. You weren't there for the Energy Wars. The dead look in their eyes, the way they killed without feeling pleasure or discomfort regarding their violence... it's unnerving." She rubs her arms and glances back down at the ship. "Whatever is in there, it's nothing I wish to see."

Her tail flicks around, like a cat nervously waiting for a hound to walk away. Cassiel hops away from me and pokes Samantha in the chest. "Come on, Sammy! It'll be fun! Hero's gonna fix up the ship, and we'll fly into space, then we'll get to see all sorts of cool stuff! Don't be a spoil-sport!"

Samantha looks a little irritated, so I pull Cassiel away and decide to try a different approach. "Suppose the robots do turn on Cassiel and I, do you want them to tear us apart? I'd expect you would want to be there in case things go south."

At my words, she groans. "Okay, okay, fine. I'll go. I'm just saying I don't like this, not one bit."

Not wanting to give her a chance to change her mind, I wordsmith once. " **Teleport.** "

All three of us arrive at the ship's bridge, and the girls both look startled for a moment but quickly shake the disorientation off. Cassiel's eyes light up as she looks around. "Wow! Look at all these computers! This feels just like home for me!"

She's very bubbly right now. It's the most I've ever seen her come out of her shell. Compared to Samantha, the one who is usually bubbly and flirty, but who now clams up around all this human technology, I almost feel as if their personalities have swapped.

As Cassiel runs around making 'boop' noises as she pokes at long-dead broken screens, I wipe the dust off a console next to me. "Are you somewhat familiar with technology?"

She nods enthusiastically. "Oh, heck yes! My mom and dad were both ex-military, so they always had all sorts of gadgets lying around the house. It was lots of fun getting to play with them and learn how they worked."

"Charming." Samantha lets a single word drawl out as she leans against a console, only for her to jerk away and rub her barely-covered butt. "Ah! It's cold..."

"Well, yeah. Metal is like that, doofus." Cassiel rolls her eyes dramatically.

All I can think about is what Cassiel just said. "Err, didn't you tell me that your childhood wasn't pleasant?"

Her smile diminishes. "Huh? Did I say something like that? Not at all! My mother and father were kind people. Other than the accident that claimed my life, everything was going quite well for me."

"Oh." I decide to leave it at that, but her words leave a sinking feeling in my stomach.

That isn't right at all. I remember what she told me about her past. Why is she changing her story now? My memory isn't screwy, and it has never been before.

Cassiel sneezes, and her wings spasm, knocking up a cloud of dust. This makes Samantha sneeze too, and she lightens up a little bit to giggle at their predicament, even as both of them sneeze again.

Something is going on. Everything is too clear, too close to a feeling that I've done much of this before. If I didn't know any better, I'd say I developed a precognition ability, in addition to my Wordsmithing. Is that possible? Will I evolve new powers as time goes on?

What about that nightmare from before? I can just barely remember it... screams of terror, a pang of despair, and possibly a face drenched in agony. Is something awful going to befall me? What if it isn't me, but Samantha and Cassiel? I can't just ignore the feeling, either. I've been predicting things all day long with uncanny accuracy. This is not the time to doubt my creepy dreams.

"Hello?" Cassiel pokes me in the rib, getting my attention.

"Huh?"

My dumb expression makes her raise an eyebrow. "I see you're off in your own little world. Well, are you going to show us the robot or what?"

Right, the robot. At the mention of OMEN, Samantha tenses up noticeably. "Robots are stupid."

"No they're not! Robots are awesome! They can shoot lasers, and fly around, and they always look so badass!"

I start walking toward the back room and the girls follow behind me.

"I know they do. That's why I don't like them." Samantha's voice has an ominous edge to it.

Seconds later, OMEN spots me walking down the hall. "Greeting: Welcome! It is good to see you once more, Supreme Commander Hiro."

"I was gone for five minutes. Don't get carried away." I flick my hand back at each of the girls. "These two are Cassiel and Samantha. They're my girlfriends. If you hurt them, I'll tear you to pieces."

Cassiel shoves past me and gawks. "Oh my gosh! No way! It's a real robot!"

"Yeah, duh. You didn't think he'd show you a lizard or something, did you?" Samantha's biting wit is only muted by her tense tone of voice.

OMEN stares ahead at nothing in particular as Cassiel pokes his face curiously. "Sooo, what's your name? I'm Cassiel!"

Despite his blank expression, his voice has a deeper tone to it than before. "Response: I am the Original Mechanical Exploratory Neohuman. My duty is to serve all those who crew this ship. I am humbled to be in the presence of an angel once more. My records indicated the angels were extinct, but I will correct them immediately."

Cassiel turns back to me, her cheeks flush with embarrassment, but also a look of awe in her eyes. "He's... he's so cute! Can we keep him?"

"Oh brother," moans Samantha, "now she's in love with it."

* * *

Carefully placing the Crown of Solomon on my head, I focus my mind on all parts of the ship around me at once. It takes a tremendous effort, but I'm able to visualize every component, every electrical connection, every important detail all at once. And finally, those thoughts explode outward as I speak a single word. " **REPAIR!** "

Immediately, things begin to happen. With an awful screeching noise, metal shifts around and folds itself back flatly along the walls. Rust vanishes, windows reform, and computer screens pop back on. The whole time, my energy is drained rapidly due to the mental strain and level of intricacy involved, but eventually, I finish, and end up depleting less than 10% of my total energy.

Cassiel is positively delighted by all the whirrs and beeps, and her eyes brighten when she sees that the front 'window' of the ship is actually a huge monitor, now displaying the ship's hull integrity as a series of green borders.

Samantha sneezes loudly. "Jeez! Hero, could you be a dear and clean the place up, too? The dust is unbearable!"

I glance down at the floor, still covered in an inch thick layer of grey sand. *I wonder how much of this dust is human remains?* I can only shudder at the thought. " **Clean!** "

Immediately, the dust vanishes and I'm suddenly blinded as the lights, no longer dimmed by eons of buildup, blast out ten times brighter than before, their light reflecting off the suddenly shiny surfaces all around us. I feel almost as if I'm standing in the center of the sun, absorbing all its light into my eyes.

Even the girls wince painfully. Cassiel takes the lead. "Computer, lower ship internal lighting brightness by 70%, if you please."

A robotic male voice, not unlike OMEN's, speaks from the ceiling. "Confirmed." The lights quickly dim again, and the three of us breathe easier.

Samantha sighs and slumps into the captain's chair on the bridge. "Okay, well, this isn't too bad, I suppose. Now that it's all cleaned up, this ship is a rather respectable thing to look at."

"Have you ever been in a spaceship before, Sammy?" Cassiel's wings slowly swish as she flops in the chair nest to Samantha. "They have all the modern amenities, you know!"

"Amenities? Like what?" Samantha tries to sound sour, but her curiosity is piqued.

"Well, they usually have fantastic bathing facilities, spas, and also replicators, so you can create any food you want instantly!" Cassiel hops out of her seat just as quickly as she sat down, and with one smooth motion, she floats over to a wall panel I hadn't noticed before. She presses a button on the panel. "Hot chocolate."

A moment later, the machine makes a whirring sound, and a brown mug appears, with warm liquid inside. Cassiel greedily sips at it, only to frown. "Huh. It doesn't taste as good as I thought. Oh well, most food doesn't. I guess angels don't need taste buds."

Samantha flits over and takes the cup from her hand and gives it a try. "Hmm. Well, I've never had this before, but it does taste quite bland."

I shrug and walk over, giving the liquid a taste. To my surprise, it tastes incredible! In fact, it might just be the best hot chocolate I've ever had in my life!

Just as I'm about to mention it's just their sense of taste, I catch an odd look in Samantha's eye, though Cassiel is too busy staring at me to notice.

That's when it clicks. *Samantha is trying to make Cassiel feel better.* If Samantha says the drink tastes good, Cassiel will be sad that she's missing out.

I almost screwed up. *Thanks, Samantha.* "This is some real swill. I think you might have hyped replicators up a little too much, Cass." I set the mug back on the replicator platform and press a button that says 'reintegrate', and a moment later, the cup and its contents vanish, sucked back up into the replicator to be recalled later.

Cassiel smiles sweetly up at me. "At least I know it's just the ship. Anyway! Let's take a bath! We're all so dirty now!"

Samantha smirks at me. "Unless you'd like to wordsmith us clean and steal the fun away."

"No, definitely not. I'm looking forward to a real bath." I give both girls a quick kiss and walk over to the captain's chair. "But first, let's see if this ship can fly."

Cassiel's eyes light up again. "Ooh! Can I be the navigator? I always wanted to fly a spaceship!"

"Sure. I don't know what I'm doing anyway, so you might as well-" I don't even finish before she shoves me out of the way and plops in the chair, clapping her hands gleefully.

Her hands move at a speed I can barely comprehend, slapping a dozen buttons in sequence, as if she's done it a hundred times before. I glance over at Samantha, and she winks at me. *Let her have some fun*, the gesture says.

The ship shudders, making me stumble around as it activates its engines and other doohickeys that will lift us into the sky. Samantha suddenly appears mortified, and she quickly sits in the nearest chair. "Oh, uh, I don't think I ever mentioned this but... I'm deathly afraid of heights. Haha...?"

Whoomph. The ship lurches up, and I topple backward, falling on my ass. Cassiel flinches. "Oops, sorry! I'm not used to the controls yet! I'll activate the inertia dampeners first next time!"

Samantha squeezes her chair's arms so hard the metal caves in. "Yes. Do that. Please."

I pull myself into my chair and smile as a feeling of excitement washes over me. The world outside starts moving as we lift up in the air, and Cassiel taps a button to change the bridge's main display into a see-through window so we can see the ground racing away. Samantha looks positively queasy.

As the ship ascends, Cassiel's smile is replaced by a look of concern. "Oh. That's odd. The ship's scanners are detecting an energy signature on the planet somewhere. It's roughly five hundred miles away and is somewhat faint, but it's definitely there."

Samantha's queasy expression is quickly replaced by a look of abject panic. "Cassiel, listen to me. Ignore it. Some things are better left undiscovered."

Cassiel snickers, "Oh, you! So jumpy! You were scared of the ship too, and look where that got us! Let's just fly over and take a quick peek! It won't hurt anything."

The succubus shakes her head quickly. "I'm serious." Her breathing quickens. "We should leave this planet and put some distance between us."

Her sudden mood shift is even making me nervous. "Samantha, does this have anything to do with the fact this planet is named Volgarius Alpha? Is this because we're on the Volgrim homeworld?"

Samantha chews on a nail. "Um. Something like that. Look, Hero, you weren't there. The Volgrim created *things* during the Energy Wars. I would prefer we not disturb anything we don't have to-

Cassiel cuts her off. "Oh, come on! I'm now the most powerful angel that's ever lived, you're the second most powerful demon emperor, and Hero is a demigod who can change reality with a single word! There is nothing we should be afraid of! I'm going to fly us over for a quick look."

Without waiting for a reply, Cassiel taps a button on the console, and the ship jerks forward, pinning Samantha and me against our seats.

Was Cassiel always this assertive? I silently wonder to myself if this is even the same girl I knew before. Maybe I wasn't paying attention, but her curiosity is insatiable.

"This is a big mistake," Samantha intones, as the horizon races toward us.

Part 429c: The Bunker

Samantha's tail twitches back and forth anxiously, like a cat waiting for a dog to sniff up a different tree, while Cassiel's wings quiver with excitement. As for me, I sit and watch the world roll by under our craft, silently wringing my hands. Samantha has been uncharacteristically reserved ever since she woke up, while Cassiel has been giddy at the thought of seeing human technology again. Somehow though, it's Samantha's outlook that's rubbing off on me. Cassiel was chained to a wall for millions of years, while Samantha knows things about the outside of the Labyrinth that Cassiel and I don't. If she's nervous about something, there's probably a good reason for it.

Samantha plays with her long black hair and jumps in her seat when a new voice in the room speaks up. "Query: Where are you directing the path of this ship?"

I glance over and spot OMEN standing behind the three of us. We're all seated in the captain, navigator, and gunner chairs respectively, so all of our backs are facing the rear of the ship. This sneaky robot must have come up while we were deep in thought, but his arrival makes Samantha unbelievably tense.

"It's not your business. Buzz off." She waves her hand dismissively at the automaton, and Cassiel scoffs.

"Sammy! That's rude. He's just asking a question."

Samantha rolls her eyes, "And I'm giving it an answer. It's none of that *thing's* business."

I decide to ignore their squabble. "We're following a faint energy reading a few hundred miles from where this ship was crashed. Do you know anything about it?"

OMEN closes his eyes for a second, then opens them again. "Processing. Tentative Response: I am aware of no such energy readings. Given this planet was once home to the Volgrim, it is entirely possible there may be an outpost here. However, the likelihood is remote. My calculations put the probability at 2.1%."

Samantha glares at the robot. "Is that so? Maybe it's just a leftover energy generator. That tech stuff might run for billions of years if nobody's using it."

Cassiel clears her throat. "Ah, well actually, Sammy, even if the power source involves fusion or the core of the planet, it would break down quickly without someone to maintain it. There's probably someone still living there." She says this so confidently that I'm not sure if she knows it's true or not. While she and Samantha debate it, I slip the Crown of Solomon on my head and

confirm that, indeed, no fusion generator or even exotic energy is likely to run forever without someone maintaining it. Even a star would eventually run out of fuel, though it would have far more material to work with than a planet.

A thought occurs to me. "OMEN, you said your ship was surveying something on this world before you crashed. Do you happen to know what that was?"

The robot stares at me blankly. "Immediate Response: Negative. I am unable to access much of the data regarding the crash. Hypothesis: The crew deliberately deleted that data prior to their deaths. Assuming this were true, I would have no way of knowing their motives or reasons as to why. Extrapolation: Something of interest was scanned, therefore they did not wish for anyone, be they human or Volgrim, to learn of its existence. The female angel's assessment of the situation is the most likely."

Cassiel smirks at him. "I have a name, you know. It's Cassiel. Calling me 'female angel' is rude."

OMEN doesn't get a chance to respond. The ship beeps an alert, and the male computer voice speaks from the ceiling again. "Unknown energy source is now five miles away. Would you like to activate the short-range scanners for more detailed information?"

Before I can respond, Cassiel beats me to it. "Yes, please activate them."

The AI chimes pleasantly. "Orders confirmed. Running short-range scans now."

Several seconds pass, and during that time, the ship passes over a mountain and travels a few miles, until soon I spot something that makes my heart skip a beat.

"Cassiel, Samantha... is that a giant metal door in the side of that mountain?"

Samantha's eyes widen, "I hope not."

Cassiel is more relaxed. "Probably. I guess this is an old Volgrim outpost. This planet is far too destabilized for life, so whoever may have once been stationed there had to have abandoned it a long time ago."

The AI blares a warning. "This vessel is being scanned. Someone is hailing us from the planet's surface. Shall I accept the request?"

Cassiel's face whitens. The pleasant expression vanishes. "The hail is audio-only. Very primitive, possibly a form of radio transmission?" She taps a button, "I'm patching it through... now."

A wheezing noise is audible from the ship speakers, and the sounds of feet scrambling in the background can be heard, along with the sound of someone putting a finger to their lips and shushing the others nearby. Seconds pass.

A man speaks. His voice is deep, and there's a sense of urgency to it. "Ahh, kree-gul, n-nowash to la... err, ellis no..." His voice is halting, and he appears to have difficulty speaking, as though he doesn't know how to pronounce his words. He gives up after a moment. "I cannot speak Volgarian very well. My name is Noah, and I am a resident of this facility. If you value your lives, you will turn your vessel around and leave. I'm sure your records show what happened to the last ship that ignored our warnings."

Cassiel taps a button, and a look of surprise is on her face. "I muted our side. His name is human, and his Volgarian is awful. No Volgrim would ever enunciate like him, so it's safe to say he's probably human."

"I agree." Samantha's expression softens, as though she has left a great deal of worry behind. "Though this raises many questions, even as it quiets a number of my concerns. We should probably take his warning and leave."

"Unmute him, Cassiel. I'd like to speak with him." I nudge her softly in the arm, and she nods. The screen beeps as our audio is enabled. "Noah, my name is, uh, Hero. I am human. I'm not here to cause any trouble; I'm just curious about your, uh, facility."

The man's breath is tight, as though he's moving around quickly, yet trying to maintain composure. "You should leave at once. This world is very hostile to human life. We cannot open the docking bay doors without killing everyone inside, and if you step out into the open air, you will die as well."

He wants us to go away. That much is clear, but I don't think he knows what's happened to the planet recently. "When was the last time you stepped outside your bunker?"

Noah breathes for several long moments before responding. "Too long."

"Can you run a scan of the planet's atmospheric composition? I think you'll be surprised by what you find."

He's wholly unconvinced. "Look, I don't know what you're trying to pull, but we've spoken for long enough. The last thing we need is for Ionis to hear about this. I'd prefer to avoid another bloodbath. I'm sorry you came all this way, but your journey was a waste of time. There isn't a chance in hell we're allowing you inside. It's for your sake, and ours."

Ionis? What kind of name is that? The thought crosses my mind, but I ignore it. "You misunderstand. I've completely altered the planet's atmosphere. It is now suitable for human life."

Noah's breath slows to a stop. "That's absurd."

A shuffling sound ensues as several people scramble about, but I can't tell what's going on otherwise. A few minutes later, Noah breathlessly speaks again. "H-how did you- this isn't possible. We would have detected an atmospheric stabilizer big enough to purify the air on this planet. What are you trying to pull here? Have you manipulated our scanners?"

I shake my head but realize he can't see me, so the gesture is wasted. "No. I am a human with special abilities. This might come as a surprise to you, but I changed the atmosphere all by myself."

Noah inhales loudly, but no words come out. A minute later, he speaks again. "What did you say your name was again?"

"Hero."

"Can you- can you spell that out for me?"

I chuckle wryly, "H-E-R-O."

"Uh huh." His voice is incredulous. I hear a faint curse under his breath. "Land your ship outside. I'm about to make a fool of myself, but my curiosity is killing me. I'll come out to you, but if you are in any way screwing with me, Ionis will make you regret it. Do I make myself clear?"

Again with the Ionis stuff. "Perfectly."

The feed cuts off without a farewell.

Cassiel blinks twice. "Well, that was rude."

* * *

Half an hour passes after our ship lands. I feel somewhat uneasy the whole time, given the people inside could be gearing up to ambush us, but OMEN calms me down. "Amused Response: This vessel is outfitted with a dozen micro-dreadnaughts and one hundred harpoon-class ion missiles. We should be able to fend off an attack from five armed Volgrim scouting ships at the same time. It is unlikely the humans inside have anything that will be able to defeat us in the event of a surprise attack. Especially given the Supreme Commander's Candidate abilities."

There's that term again. "OMEN, what is a Candidate? You keep calling me that, but I'm not certain I know what it is."

OMEN plasters another creepy smile across his face. "Commentary: Given your acknowledgment that you are a candidate, in addition to your displays of magical power, it is highly unlikely you do not know what a Candidate is. This unit is capable of detecting sarcasm at an elevated rate compared to the average human."

"But... but I wasn't being sarcastic."

Cassiel interrupts me. "A side door just opened. It's smaller than the main door, just big enough for a human to enter and exit. Ah! One person is coming out."

All three of us lean forward and squint at the screen until Cassiel talks again. "Computer, magnify on the human, zoom level eight."

The computer beeps in the affirmative and the human is enhanced. Based on what Noah said, this is probably him. He's wearing a full-body containment suit, likely to filter out the contaminants he thinks are in the atmosphere.

Noah slowly walks forward, stopping every ten feet or so to look at a computer screen attached to the wrist of his suit before continuing again. After five minutes, he stops, looks up at our ship, and slowly pulls off his helmet.

He's an older man. If I had to guess, I'd say mid-50's. His hair isn't grey yet, but a few strands are lighter than the rest. His big, bushy black beard surrounds his pale skin in such a way that it looks almost out of place. If I had to make a snap judgment, I'd assume he's been in many fistfights and knows how to throw down.

Cassiel taps a button to lower our ship's landing ramp, then looks at me and smiles sweetly. "Let's go greet him!"

A minute later, we step out onto the dry landscape as a gentle, rustling breeze blows past. The air, as always, smells stale and unlike the world I was born on, yet not unpleasant. Noah watches silently as the girls and I walk down the ramp.

"So you're 'Hero', huh?" His eyes flick from me to Cassiel on my right, and Samantha on my left. "A human, an angel, and a demon. Considering angels are extinct, last I heard anyway, this is a sight I never expected to see in my lifetime."

"We're his girlfriends." Samantha forces a smile, but it doesn't feel sincere.

"Great. What's with the, err, tattoos?" Noah stares at my face carefully, likely watching the shimmering lines that cover my entire body, brightening and dimming as I breathe. Contrasted with my skin, which is far more tanned than in my youth when I was a pasty teenager, it lends me a somewhat frightening appearance. Noah doesn't appear disturbed though.

"I absorbed the energy of three ancient archangels."

My explanation is apparently sufficient for him. "I suppose that makes sense, at least as much as anything else so far. What do you want with our outpost, anyway?" His eyes shift again to examine our ship. "And why are you flying around in... that? It's been a long time since I saw a ship resembling yours."

I decide to skip the part where we found it on this planet. Noah doesn't recognize it, so he probably doesn't know about the crash site, and I'd prefer not to give him too many clues. "It's a fixer-upper. I repaired it with my powers."

"Oh." He scratches his beard thoughtfully. "I'm torn. On the one hand, I have a thousand questions for you. On the other hand, you're risking your lives every second you stay here. If Ionis decides you're a threat, there isn't anything we can do to stop him."

I open my mouth to ask what this 'Ionis' is he keeps referring to, but he shakes his head and continues talking. "Then again, Lady Victoria was quite clear that I can use my judgment exclusively regarding your crew. If you're willing to risk your lives, you can enter our facility."

Risk our lives? "Can I at least ask who this Ionis is? The name certainly isn't human."

Noah raises an eyebrow and chuckles. "It's better if you don't know. You definitely wouldn't go inside if you did."

I hate cryptic people. I want to tell him off, but Samantha nudges me. "Hero, let's just leave. We don't need to go inside, do we?"

As usual, her prodding only awakens Cassiel's ferocious curiosity. "Don't be a spoilsport! There's nothing we have to be afraid of!"

Her comment makes a question pop into my head. "Noah, don't you realize you could be making a grave mistake? What if we're hostile? Letting us in could doom your base."

His smile widens dramatically. "Haha! That's a good one! If you killed me now, you wouldn't get off this planet alive. If you go inside and make one wrong move, I don't care how powerful you *think* you are, Ionis will kill you instantly. Anyway, are you coming, or not?"

All I can do is scowl. This smells super fishy, and Samantha's unease seems to wash over my left, while Cassiel's curiosity splashes over my right. I don't know what to do, but at this point, I just want my questions answered.

"We'll go in. We don't mean any harm, so hopefully 'Ionis' realizes we're good people."

"Yay!" Cassiel hops up and down, while Samantha groans.

"Samantha, if you want, you can stay here. I'm not going to force you to come along."

She ignores my warning. "I'll go."

I guess that settles it.

* * *

A few minutes later, we stand before the massive metal hangar doors that lead into whatever the facility is. The hole in the mountainside rounds into an oval shape at the top and each door

stands over a hundred feet tall. Perhaps it's an old reconditioned starship base? Noah walks over to the side entrance I saw before and stands, staring blankly at it. After a minute, there's a hissing sound, and the entrance creaks open an inch. Noah reaches into the crack and heaves with all his strength, pulling against what must be eons of rust on the hinges.

Once it's open, the four of us step inside. A white plastic/ceramic alcove has been built around the door, along with a ventilation system that travels up and outside. "Decontamination room. It used to be necessary before you purified the planet's air," Noah says. "assuming you actually did that, of course."

Noah throws the door open on the other side and strides out into the main hangar area. I follow after him, and the girls are right behind me. We're immediately greeted by what must be fifty men and women, all of them unarmed, staring at the four of us with wide eyes. Most of them look quite old, and many of them must be retirees, judging by the grey hair and sagging skin. Still, there are some younger thirty-somethings among them, and the younger men's eyes immediately shoot to Samantha, staring right at her tightly fitting 'clothes.' I use the term in the barest meaning, given she wears strips of fabric that hardly cover anything. I'm used to it by now, but the guys here aren't.

Noah waves his hand chidingly. "Let's not crowd, everyone. Give our guests some space. It's not often we have visitors in the first place."

"Indeed." A woman steps forward, older than all the others here by a long shot, leaning heavily on a cane. Her long blonde hair stands out, along with the strange outfit she's wearing, something ancient - even by my standards. It's a dress, dark green in color, with puffy shoulders and a skirt that stretches down to the tips of her toes. A veil lightly covers her face, and my immediate impression is that of 1500's nobility. Indeed, people step out of the way to give her extra room as she ambles over to me. Despite her wrinkled face and dry skin, her blonde hair shows that age is just a number for her.

"Lady Victoria. These were the only three aboard that ship." Noah tips his head at her. "The man is, err, Hero... as for the other two..."

I suddenly remember I didn't introduce the girls. "This is Cassiel, and this is Samantha."

The woman, Victoria, narrows her eyes. "Dark times must be ahead. A Hero has arisen, and he is followed by the Second Emperor of Hell, along with a member of an extinct species. Ionis will, no doubt, see you as a threat. I wonder if you will perish."

Samantha pushes past me. "Hold on. How do you know I'm the Second Emperor? That information is hardly known to anyone these days."

Victoria nods slowly, "I know many things, Belial. Once, a long time ago, it was my job to learn the secrets of the galaxy, and never reveal them. Even now, looking at the clear embodiment of the Hero, a harbinger of a system I had thought destroyed, I know it to be alive and well. The question I am asking myself is... why now, of all times, has a Hero appeared? And why on Volgarius Alpha, I wonder?"

Samantha stares at the old woman for a few long moments. "I'm terrible with names and faces. Do I know you?"

"We used to be mortal enemies, during the Energy Wars." Victoria raises a finger and waves it at her. "But then, I suppose all humans look the same to a demon, eh?"

"Something like that." Samantha rasps the words out, "So how do you know me?"

"My full name is Victoria Vanheimmer Rothschild. Once, when Earth was still around, and my secret society was at their prime, I ruled humanity from the shadows, seeking to eliminate the demonic and angelic control over humanity. Now I know that I failed."

Samantha's eyes widen. "Rothschild. That isn't a name I would soon forget. You must have led the Illuminati."

"And you said your memory was poor." Victoria *tut-tut's* to herself. "Welcome to the final resistance against the Volgrim. This is the one place they will never openly assault no matter what. Come, I'll take you to our guardian."

Victoria doesn't wait for us to respond, instead shambling off past the crowd again. Noah follows after her, and so I tag along behind him.

Once we've moved past the distracting mutterings of the crowd, I can finally examine the facility itself. Cassiel's excitement returns in full force as I look around. Inside this underground bunker, a ramp stretches down, over a hundred feet wide, at least a mile underground. The bunker expands the deeper we walk in, and soon I assume it's big enough to fit Godzilla comfortably, along with ten other giant lizard monsters. Catwalks line the walls all around us, and everywhere we walk, people stand on the catwalks to stare at us in silence. Hundreds of people of all races, ages, and sizes watch our every move.

"How many people live here?" I decide to ask the question on my mind, even as I spot what can only be described as *alcoves* on the walls. Some of them are a hundred feet tall, others only as tall as myself. They look like the sort of thing I'd stick a human inside to recharge their bodies... or whatever. Even the shapes of the alcoves are vaguely human.

Noah glances back at me. "A few thousand people. We started off with only fifty or so, and boredom took over at one point, but we had to put limitations on fraternizing. Procreation is

expressly prohibited, and if any pregnancies occur, we execute the children immediately. Our facility simply can't handle the load, given how much power it takes for replicators to produce food for all of us."

Cassiel hops excitedly. "Oooh! How are you powering a facility of this size?! You must be using cold fusion or something exotic!"

Noah shakes his head and looks forward again. "Nothing like that. We're using energy taken directly from the planet's core. Still, the energy we need might not seem like much, especially given how much energy a planet can put out... but we've been trapped here for tens of millions of years. We don't have the tools to escape, and nothing is waiting for us outside even if we did. We can't build new energy sources or more replicators. It's been a struggle since the very beginning."

"For the Illuminati to fall this far..." Victoria grumbles to herself. "It's a shame."

Cassiel taps her chin. "As I thought. You must be using nanobots to stay alive, then. I'm surprised you've lived so long, given the nano-cancer's infection rate."

I'm not sure what she's talking about at all, but I know a little bit about the Illuminati from my time in junior high when I found random occult webpages and looked around them for fun. I barely remember any of that stuff now though.

"We *invented* the nano-cancer. Obviously, the leader of the Illuminati would be immune to it. Even so," Victoria smooths down the fluff on one of her shoulder-puffs, "it has not been without its downsides."

I don't know what she means, but Cassiel seems to understand.

We walk in silence, and I feel slightly disturbed by how far we've traveled. We're already a mile underground, and this long tunnel keeps going down all the time, all while the facility expands around us the further underground we go. Surely without pillars to support the roof, this place is susceptible to a cave-in?

Noah inhales sharply. "We're here. Ionis will assess you now."

Stepping to the side, Noah beckons for us to step forward. An illuminated alcove on the wall stands out from the others.

Inside that alcove is a being made of pure metal. A robot, to be sure, but without any visible joints or mechanical parts. Its body is made of a sleek, shiny titanium-style alloy, and aside from its six-fingered hands, the thing that stands out most to me is a lone blood-red 'eye.' The robot has a single retinal light that spins around its entire head in any direction, and as we

stand before it, the robot doesn't move an inch, but its eye jerks from me, to Cassiel, to Samantha.

Samantha, I now realize, is quivering in terror. "J-just as I thought. It's a Sentinel."

Part 430c: Ionis

The man who calls himself 'Hero' stares up at the robot, a hint of wonder and fear in his eyes. It is a look everyone in my facility once shared. Given the eons we have lived with Ionis protecting us, it is only natural that our fear and distrust have given way to admiration and reverence. After all, Ionis saved us from the Volgrim, in a most brutal and spectacular fashion. We owe him our very lives, though a silent guardian he might be.

The playthings that Hero brought along with himself include Belial, the second most powerful demon in existence, and 'Cassiel' an oddity even for an angel, given her alarmingly high level of spiritual energy, and the fact that all angels should have long since perished at the end of the Energy Wars. Despite the ridiculous power that these two hold, both of them hold similar looks of terror on their faces, though the demon girl is the most obvious.

Funny. From what I hear, the Sentinels only ever killed humans and Volgrim, yet it is a demon who fears them the most of everyone in this hangar. Times do change.

The angel speaks, her voice barely a whisper. "Victoria, what is this thing? I've never seen a robot like it before."

The demoness balls her hands into fists. "It is a Sentinel, a weapon of last resort created by the Volgrim. I've never fought one, nor wanted to, but humans who survived the Energy Wars spoke of them in only muted whispers. Most are long dead." She looks at me with suspicion in her eyes. "Funny, last I heard, Sentinels were machines of carnage. How the hell have you managed to stay alive with one in your midst?"

I have nothing to fear from the Second Emperor, so long as Ionis favors my people. Her anger means little to me. "I don't know the answer. Ionis has never harmed any human at this base. Only once has he ever moved from his alcove, and that was to save us from a Volgrim attack force hellbent on destroying us."

Noah, my bumbling assistant, coughs into his fist. "Ah, actually, Lady Victoria, those Volgrim were just part of a scouting party. They didn't even know we were down here."

"Are you correcting me?" I glare at the ignoramus. "I can remember our past just fine, thank you very much."

A pained look appears in his eyes. "Yes, of course. I must have... misremembered."

That's not even a word, stupid. I ignore the slight and smile sweetly back at the other three. "In any case, other than protecting us from a pack of ravenous monsters, Ionis has never

moved."

A smile appears on the angel girl's face. "Maybe he's a nice robot! He looks a little scary, but you can't judge a book by its cover."

"Have you ever *read* a book?" Belial rolls her eyes, "Anyway, how do you know its name? Can the thing talk?"

Noah rubs his hands together slowly. "If Ionis can speak, he's never done it before. The files on his name, along with the other Sentinel names were in the computer databanks on this planet when we found it."

Hero, ever the quiet one, speaks up, surprising me. "I just realized... are all of these other alcoves for other Sentinels?"

An astute observation. I open my mouth to answer, but at that moment, I catch a hint of movement from the corner of my eye. I stop and look at Ionis, but he hasn't moved an inch. Wait! His hand twitched!

A second later, Ionis's red eye swivels to aim directly at Hero, and he raises his six-fingered hand to point at the man.

Hero blinks. "Huh? Me? What do you want?"

Our guardian doesn't respond. For a few seconds, the Hero and Sentinel lock eyes on each other, when suddenly an awful humming noise explodes in the air! Like the sound of a million bees from my home planet of Earth buzzing in a sphere surrounding the entire hangar, the air vibrates with a fiery rage, and every person in the hangar cups their ears and opens their mouths to scream silently.

Just as quickly as the awful humming comes, it disappears. I nearly drop my cane and fall, but luckily my assistant manages to catch me. "Lady Victoria! Careful!"

I decide not to yell at him this time, and instead just nod. "Thank you, Noah. What was that terrible racket?"

"I don't know." He glances up at Ionis. "I think the Sentinel made it."

Hero pokes his finger in his ear and wiggles it around a few seconds, before narrowing his eyes at the robot. "Founders? I've never heard of them."

This time, there's a much fainter humming, almost like a dog whistle I can scarcely distinguish from background noise. Hero grits his teeth and glares at the robot. "I certainly didn't destroy the Sentinels! You've got me mixed up with someone else!"

"Hero? Is the robot talking to you?" Belial leans forward and touches his arm lightly, but he ignores her.

More humming. "Of course I'm not lying. You're the first Sentinel I've ever seen." He pauses as more humming comes. "Well, now you're just being rude."

This time when the humming stops, Hero simply sighs. "That's a tall order. I'll think about it."

Hero turns to his girl toys and scratches his forehead. "The uh... the robot wants to join us on our journey."

"Absolutely not!" Belial nearly jumps out of her skin, the poor dear. "Don't we get a say in this?"

As for me, I don't like the sound of that either. "If Ionis leaves, we will have no protection. All of our weapons are aged and broken. A primitive with a sturdy spear could pacify our aged populace at this point."

"Yeah, I understand." Hero glowers at our guardian for a moment. "I'll think about his request. In the meantime, the three of us will go to our spaceship and talk it over."

They start to turn their backs to walk away, but Noah rises to the occasion. "Actually, if you'd like, you can stay and have dinner with us. We don't have visitors very often, so I'm sure everyone would enjoy meeting you."

Heh, smart move. Sometimes my assistant manages to think on his feet and impress me. In truth, I want to speak with this so-called 'Hero.' His sudden appearance, alongside such mighty angel and demon girls, tells me something is afoot. Heroes, along with angels, were supposed to be extinct. The fact that he is here, now, means that humanity has a slim chance to stage a return.

Hero looks uncomfortable. He wants to return back to his ship, but it would be rude to turn Noah's offer down. He finally relents. "Yeah, dinner sounds good."

Noah is so sly.

* * *

The massive dining hall catches my eye immediately. At least a hundred metal tables, along with several similarly styled chairs, are lined up in aisles for people to come and sit on them. It reminds me of a school cafeteria, or perhaps one belonging to a prison. The lights above flicker occasionally, and the floor is rather grimy. The whole place has a melancholic, machine-like feel to it. Nobody looks particularly happy or sad; they merely seem to exist.

All around us, people are dressed in similar uniforms, each one worn out and tattered, with a logo I've never seen before. It resembles a dove with a few leaves in its mouth, and the dove is flying above the waves of an ocean, as if carrying hope in its beak.

Noah spots me looking at one of the uniforms on a man's back. "What's wrong? Is there something on your mind?"

I shake my head and watch as a giant platter of food is picked up by six men, and slowly walked over to our table, the one at the head of the cafeteria. The table doesn't look particularly special, but its position tells me it belongs only to the 'important' people of the facility, and nobody else is allowed to sit here. "That logo isn't anything I've seen before. I'm just wondering what it stands for."

Noah nods, pulling back as the men set the platter down and bow before walking away. "I made the logo myself; it's based on a story I remember reading as a child. Noah's Ark. As the tale goes, all the people of Earth defied God, so he swore to strike them down. Only one man and his family were spared God's wrath, by hiding inside an 'ark' and riding atop the waves of a great flood. When the time came, they released a dove, over and over again, until the dove brought them leaves from dry land."

I nod along with his explanation, as Victoria ambles over, Cassiel and Samantha chatting to her the whole time. "That's from the Bible. I mostly remember how the story goes."

Surprise in his eye, Noah smiles genuinely at me. "Really? You've heard the story before?"

"Yup. I was never big on reading the Bible, honestly. I used to be something of an atheist until I realized demons and angels were, y'know... real."

"The Bible, huh?" Noah taps his chin thoughtfully, "I don't remember anything about that book, other than the story of Noah's Ark. That's why my parents gave me my name. They said someday I would lead the chosen few of humanity to safety." His eyes flick around the room. "Not exactly what I expected, but this is close enough."

Samantha and Cassiel sit in the uncomfortable metal chairs to either side of me, while Victoria pulls up a chair directly across from the three of us, next to Noah. "I'm starving! I don't eat as much as I used to, but I still love food! It makes me feel human, you know."

Cassiel fidgets in her seat, "That must be nice."

Victoria ignores her and nudges the heavy platter over toward us. "Dig in! It may have been tens of millions of years since we've had guests, but even a dummy knows to wait until the visitors have started!"

Samantha eyes the food with disinterest. Neither she nor Cassiel requires food to survive, and in fact, Samantha has confided that *male essence* is her most favorite thing to consume. As for Cassiel, she still likes to eat food, but she lacks the taste buds she once had as a human. Both of them are trying to be polite though, so they take small portions of rice and potatoes.

Noah smiles pleasantly at me. "Try the chicken. It's to die for."

I swallow a lump of bile. "Th-that sounds *great*." It doesn't. I spear a small leg of it on my plate along with some of the other food, but it's the fish that catches my eye. "How are you able to eat food like this? Surely you aren't breeding animals here, are you?"

Victoria waves her wrinkled hand dismissively. "Pish! It's all from the replicators! We've spent so much time trying to figure out how this facility stays maintained or where the energy comes from, but we gave up a long time ago. Without any tuning, this facility always runs smoothly. Though, the energy per day does have a limit... which is one reason we keep the population in check."

Cassiel stops sliding food around on her plate as interest passes over her face. "Oh? How do the energy limits work?"

Victoria shrugs, "Oh, I don't know. The planet gets colder at night or something. This makes the core generate less energy. It's not that interesting if you ask me."

Noah pauses eating to stifle a grimace. " *Actually*, most of our scientists theorize it's because there's a battery system somewhere that drains whenever we use energy. Once the battery empties, the lights go out until the core can re-energize it."

His response just makes Victoria roll her eyes. "Oh *thank you*, Noah. It's a big battery. *That* makes sense."

He quickly lowers his head back down to stuff more potatoes in his mouth. "Sorry."

Everyone sits in silence for a short while, glancing around, unsure of what to say as we eat little by little. Finally, Samantha nudges her plate away, then smiles sweetly at Victoria. "That was delicious. Thank you for the meal."

"You're welcome, demoness." Victoria smiles curtly, and for once I realize that despite her posturing, she doesn't like demons all that much. Something about the look in her eyes tells me she doesn't trust Samantha at all. She looks at me and sighs. "So, your name is Hero, hmm?"

An odd question. That wasn't what I was expecting. "Something like that. My real name is Jason Hiro, but nobody calls me by that name."

"I see. But you are a 'hero', correct? That is, a descendant of the Hero System?"

Her stare makes me feel a little uncomfortable. "What's the Hero System? I've never heard of it."

"So you don't know." It's a statement, not a question. "Angels created the Hero System. As head of the Illuminati, the knowledge of each previous head was passed down to me. I know a great many things about the angels, things that few still living do."

Samantha chimes in blandly, "People other than me?"

"Yes. Even you, I am guessing, don't know the exact method with which the Heroes' power was awakened. Honestly, my memory has grown rather fuzzy after being cooped up on this planet for so long, but I can't forget the details that were passed down to me. Humanity's future depends on my knowledge."

I slide the untouched chicken leg around on my plate thoughtfully, leaning a little closer to her. "What do you mean by 'humanity's future'? Aren't all humans trapped in the Labyrinth, waiting for demons to devour them? I've seen many bubble worlds in the years I've spent looking."

Samantha sucks in her breath suddenly. "Oh, love, you could have just asked me. There are many humans outside of the Labyrinth. In fact, one thing that has caused demons much consternation is the problem that they can't locate all them. Humans are quite weak, unable to put up much of a fight, but very good at hiding. I was sickened by how the Volgrim and other demon leaders weren't willing to let the stragglers live in peace, which is why I left the High Domains of Hell."

"How admirable of you," This time, it's Victoria who drawls at Samantha. "I guess you feel pretty good about yourself, then?"

"I do." Samantha flicks her gaze away, "Not all demons are vile monsters, you know."

"I would hope not."

The sudden tension at the table makes me glance between the two uneasily. "Is there something I'm missing?"

Samantha practically jumps at the chance to reply before Victoria can. "It's not your fault, Hero. You couldn't possibly know this, but the entire basis for the Illuminati's existence was the highest form of xenophobia. They believed humans shouldn't be bound by angels and demons manipulating them, which is well and good, but the Illuminati also believed that humans were *better* than the other species. You could say they were purists of a sort." Samantha shoots a nasty glare at Victoria. "But if humans were so mighty, why have they fallen so far?"

Now it's Victoria's turn to glare nastily at Samantha. "Demons hadn't a chance of beating humans fairly. You had to kiss the rumps of your alien overlords to stand a chance against us. It took the combined might of two sentients to enslave humanity. Once again, I ask you, do you feel pretty good about yourself and how things ended up?"

Samantha's anger fizzles out. "When you put it that way, no. I don't like how things turned out."

I decide to intervene. "Victoria, back to the topic from earlier. What is the Hero System?"

She continues to stare at Samantha but answers my question anyway. "The angels, looking for a way to tip the balance of power in their favor in the war against the demons, while also mitigating humanity's weaknesses, created the Hero System. It's simple. A single human would gain incredible power for his or her entire life. Once that human died, the power would transfer to another. They kept the requirements vague enough, but for some reason, the power always seemed to favor humans born with blonde hair and blue eyes. Many legendary humans were given this heroic power, and things worked out rather well in the war against the demons."

I quickly glance at Samantha. Luckily, she doesn't seem too disturbed about this 'war against the demons' talk. I suppose it's because she doesn't need to feel insecure when she could kill every human in this room with no trouble at all. I turn back to Victoria, "That's interesting. I never questioned where my power came from, but I guess that explains a few things."

"Oh yes. It's quite interesting. But more importantly, it's how the angels created that power. Even Belial doesn't know this much." The old woman smiles far too sweetly for my liking and taps her lip thoughtfully. "You see, the angels, desperate to create a weapon to combat the demons, had a meeting among themselves. That is, among the highest archangels and gods. They came to a unanimous decision to sacrifice one archangel's life to create this power. The angel would be placed inside a container for safekeeping, a ring as it were, and his immense energy would be used to craft the soul."

For once, Samantha no longer looks angry or bored. Instead, she turns to look at Victoria incredulously. "How can you possibly know all of this?"

"The Illuminati had many names before we became a feared secret society. 'Skull and Bones.' 'Knights of the Round Table.' 'Templars.' In fact, the founder of the Illuminati's progenitor namesake was the Fourth Hero. We've had kings, queens, popes, and even demons and angels under our influence over the millennia."

Samantha raises an eyebrow questioningly, "The fourth hero? Who was that?"

Victoria waves her hand nonchalantly. "If you don't remember, I won't bother to explain. In any case, that isn't the important thing I'm getting at. The important tidbit is the identity of that

archangel who was chosen to be sacrificed. *Hades* was his name."

She speaks the name as if it's significant, but when I glance at Samantha, she stares ahead blankly. "Am I supposed to recognize that name?"

As for myself, I can only shrug. In the Bible, he was the king of the underworld or something like that, but the Bible and other historical texts have always been somewhat unreliable when it came to descriptions of gods and demons.

"I suppose not. Hades's sacrifice is what made the Hero System function. Three simple criteria must be met for the Soul to transfer. First, the hero in question must die. *Obviously*. Second, there must be a suitable Candidate to obtain the soul. Finally, and most importantly, there must be angels still alive."

This time, both of the girls and myself are alert and interested. Cassiel shoves her plate aside. "Why are angels required?"

"Oh, that's simple enough. The Heroic Spirit drains the combined energy of all living angels to transfer to the next human. If no angels are alive, with enough energy that the Soul can drain, then, in theory, it should wither and die." Victoria inhales and exhales dramatically. "So, with everything I've told you now, you can understand why your presence fills everyone here with such hope. If you are here, along with an angel, that means other angels still live. The Heroic Spirit must have lain dormant, passing from person to person, waiting until just the right moment to reappear. When it did, you awakened."

The look of awe fades from my face. "You're wrong. At least, I think you are. Just before my 18th birthday, I froze myself in a cryopod. I stayed inside for over a hundred million years. When I thawed, I was inside the Labyrinth. I probably had my powers before I even entered the pod."

Victoria and Noah's smiles both fade as well, but Victoria's expression still holds something resembling hope. "But, the angel beside you. Others must still be alive, yes?"

Cassiel shakes her head slowly. "I'm the last one."

Noah frowns, "But Jason, didn't you say that you absorbed the energy of three Archangels?"

I smile weakly, and hold up my hands, displaying the three rings for all to see. "These are rings of the Archangels, much like what you described for Hades."

"Oh." Victoria slumps in her chair a little. "This is... disheartening. If you perish, all chances for humanity to stage a comeback will vanish. Well, unless..." She smiles sweetly at Cassiel, "...unless you have enough energy to continue the transfer process by yourself."

This time, Cassiel smiles back before winking at me. "That might be doable. We've been gaming the system for a while now!"

Noah coughs loudly. "Say, about your powers... you managed to completely alter the atmosphere of this planet all by yourself, so if you don't mind me asking...?"

"Are you asking what my power is? Well, cat's out of the bag already. I call it 'wordsmithing.' I can make anything happen with a single word."

Noah nods slowly, "Riiight, so that means what, exactly?"

A demonstration is in order. I look down at the disgusting chicken leg in front of me. "**Transform.**"

Seconds later, the chicken leg reshapes itself into a small sword, roughly the size of a kitchen knife, but resembling a letter opener a friend of mine from the past used to have on his desk.

"OHHH!" Noah almost jumps out of his seat in excitement. "What else can you do?!"

His excitement is contagious. "I don't usually like to show off... but I can probably make an exception, just this one time."

"Oh, Hero! You're such a nerd sometimes!" Cassiel teases me, then whispers into my ear, "Use the crown, then you can make some *really* wild things."

She seems to mean something naughty, but her suggestion gives me an idea. "Actually, if that Sentinel is going to come with us, I might have a solution for not leaving you defenseless."

* * *

As we walk out of the cafeteria, leaving behind a crowd of people gawking and laughing at the colossal pile of weapons I created for them, Noah smiles widely at me. "That was incredible! Your power seems to have no limit! As a man of science, I'm dying to know what else you can do!"

I rub my head and laugh. "Haha! Another time, perhaps. That took a lot of energy out of me, and usually, I need to nap after a summoning session like-" An old man with a scraggly looking beard suddenly shoves past me, stumbling around while the smell of alcohol lingers on his breath.

The old man coughs and glares up at me. "Hey! Watch where yer' walkin', asshole!" His clothes are torn and mangled, and he looks a little different from the other people. He vanishes into the crowd behind me a moment later.

Noah smacks his head and smiles apologetically to me. "Oh, sorry about that. Lee can be such a pain sometimes."

"It's no problem." I dust myself off, and as we exit the room, Samantha and Cassiel wave at me. Both of them have been outside the cafeteria, chatting with Victoria. At least they seem to be getting along now. "There's my girls."

"You're a lucky man, honestly." Noah cracks his neck and winces. "You have all that power, two beautiful women at your side, and you get to travel the cosmos. I'd be lying a little bit if I said I wasn't jealous. Everyone here is old, and none of us are ever in the mood to have a little loving. All we do is work and play cards."

"Work, huh?" He and I stop a few dozen feet away. "What kind of work are you up to?"

He shrugs, "We mostly just mine. We've been digging further and further inside the planet since the atmosphere outside was toxic, at least until you showed up. Most of our furniture is fabricated from metal we dug out of the planet."

"Hmm. I see. Would you prefer to live on the surface if you could?"

He nods back. "I haven't seen a star or a sun in so long... I'd kill for it. We have to take Vitamin D supplements just to survive."

I jot down a mental note before turning back and walking toward the women. "Before I leave, I'll fix those problems."

"Which ones?"

"All of them."

Cassiel grins cheerfully at me as I approach. "So we're taking Mr. Sentinel with us, right?"

Samantha's smile vanishes abruptly. "Are you still on about that?"

As for me, I feel uncomfortable suddenly. The words Ionis beamed into my mind earlier come rushing back.

YOU DISASSEMBLED THE SENTINELS. YOU MUST REBUILD US. TAKE ME TO THE FOUNDERS.

I turn to Victoria. "Before I go, I just have to ask a question. It's regarding Ionis's request-what are the Founders?"

She glances at me, at Samantha, and back again. "Well, given the Sentinels are a Volgrim creation, I would assume he means the Volgrim Founders."

Samantha looks uneasy. "All five of them are dead. Why would he want to go see them, anyway?"

"So he can rebuild the other Sentinels, I guess."

My response makes a wave of shocked expressions pass around the group; all save Cassiel.

Noah sputters, "W-what?! He wants to rebuild the Sentinels?! That's- that is a terrible idea!"

Samantha, obviously, agrees. "Of course! We can't rebuild them! They're the most dangerous weapon in existence!"

I play along. "Oh, hmm, yes I suppose you're right. In that case, which one of you wants to tell the murder-death robot of unstoppable power 'no'?"

The looks of shock pass quickly. Samantha rubs her arm sheepishly and looks away. "Well, when you put it that way..."

Now, only Cassiel is the one out of the loop. "Call me silly, but what do we have to fear? Why not just destroy the robot if it's so dangerous? Didn't you say all the other ones were defeated already? That means it isn't invincible!"

"She has a point." Victoria, of all the people, agrees. "The only problem is that we have no idea *who* defeated them, or *how* they did it."

I suddenly feel a little nervous. "Well, actually, Ionis said that *I* was the one who destroyed the Sentinels. That's pretty stupid since it couldn't have been me. He then said something about my vital signs being indicative of someone telling the truth, so it wasn't me, but the whole thing was a bit confusing."

Everyone looks slightly defeated. Victoria smiles at me. "Well, as you said, it would be stupid to refuse our guardian's request. If you don't know how to defeat him in combat, don't even try." A dark expression appears on her face. "I still remember the carnage; the bodies left in his wake. When the Volgrim sent their mightiest ship to kill us, Ionis vanished from his alcove in an instant. We'd never seen him move before, and less than a minute later, he returned. He was completely covered in blood and bone."

Noah groans, "It was awful. We spent years cleaning up the remains of the ship and burying evidence of it. It sent a signal to a different vessel in orbit above us at some point, so we're certain the Volgrim learned of our existence, but none bothered us ever since. Given what the Sentinels did during the Energy Wars, I'm sure the Volgrim are as terrified of them as we used to be."

"Used to be?" Samantha echoes Noah's words. "How could you ever move past the fear of a Sentinel? The idea is preposterous. I'd never turn my back on one."

"We've had eons. We learned Ionis meant us no harm." Victoria sighs, "In any case, make your decision. Now that you've armed us, I'm sure we could at least use the threat of having a Sentinel if the Volgrim show up again. If they don't fall for it, we can fight back. Your only question now is whether or not you will take Ionis with you."

A *very* short deliberation between the girls and I answers the question handily. "Cassiel already wanted him to come along, and Samantha and I aren't keen on pissing him off."

"I hope this works out well for you, Hero." Victoria offers words of encouragement, and somehow, they make me feel just a little bit better about the whole situation.

* * *

An hour later, Ionis walks behind the girls and me onto our spaceship. The entire group of people from the colony have spilled out behind us in front of the giant metal doors, some staring up at the sun, others watching Ionis, and the rest staring at our back as we take our leave.

"Farewell, Hero! The four of you hold the fate of the universe in your hands!" Noah waves goodbye, and we enter our ship, blasting off from the planet's surface.

I slump into the captain's chair, Cassiel sits in the navigator's seat, and Samantha takes the gunner's position. All the while, Ionis stands at attention behind us, practically leaning against the wall.

"You know," Cassiel says, thoughtfully, "Since Ionis is Volgrim in nature, doesn't that mean we have a representative for all four species among us now?"

"No," Samantha shakes her head quickly, "Ionis is a robot, plain and simple. We already had one of those."

In my mind, I hear Ionis speak again. *YOU WILL TAKE ME TO THE FOUNDERS.*

I don't know what to say. I can't just tell him they're all dead. I don't want him to rebuild an army. For now, I had better just play along.

As the ship exits the atmosphere, I remember my mental checklist. "Stop here for a moment, Cassiel. I need to take care of some things."

"Hm?" She taps buttons and stops us just above the atmosphere. "What are you up to?"

"I'm just keeping my word, as a Hero should."

I wordsmith the Crown back onto my head and carefully aim my mind at the humans on the surface below. " **Youth. Beauty.** "

With that done, my energy is still quite full, despite what I told them. " **Terraform! Ecology! Plants! Anim-** " I catch myself as a sudden wave of nausea hits me, along with a massive draining of my energy. Before I realize it, I taste blood.

Cassiel quickly heals me and gives me a metric ton of energy from herself. "Careful! Don't overdo it!"

"I won't. Sorry." My head feels a little woozy, but once again, I use the crown to focus my mind like never before. Picturing all animals from Earth, their biology, the entirety of the food cycle, and that which creates a food chain, I speak again. " **ANIMALS! BACTERIA! TREES!** "

This time, I manage to finish, sighing in relief as I slump back into my chair. I feel as if I've bitten onto an anvil with all of my might. My jaw hurts, my head stings with pain, and my stomach roils. But still... I succeeded. I smile as the ship's display shows the planet rapidly turning green below me. An ecological and biological indicator rockets upward as plants, animals, and millions of other things appear all at once. With luck, the planet will be able to sustain itself. I can always come back in the future and fix any anomalies.

"Cassiel. Set a course for Earth."

She looks at me in surprise. "Earth? Aren't we just outside of a bubble world?"

I shake my head and smile at her, as the need for sleep starts to overcome me. "No. We're back in the normal universe. We're home."

Part 431c: Nightmare

I can't see anything. The fog around me is so thick and dense; it reminds me of smoke. I want to choke on it, but I can't breathe. *Your fault*, whisper the voices in the distance. I pull my body across the ground, an inch at a time, but my left arm isn't working. My right arm has to do all the work, and I'm starting to sweat from exhaustion. Light permeates this void from every direction, but it has no central source.

"Is somebody out there?"

My voice is weak and fragile. I feel broken, like a horse worked to death twice over. Between the fog around me and the fear inside, I couldn't fight off an aggressive mouse if my life depended on it.

A word hisses through the fog, directed at me. *Failure*. The voice congeals into something sinister. The speaker is close. I pull myself forward again, and this time, my hand touches something *leathery*. Using all my strength, I lift my head up to see an all-too-familiar specter staring down at me.

"You killed them."

The man looking back at me is none other than myself. I feel a shiver go down my back as I gaze at the black robes and smoke rising from his body. *He's* the reason this place is choked and dead.

"Who? I didn't kill anyone!"

I offer a weak plea, but he merely shakes his head.

"You have killed many. Heroes shouldn't lie."

I try to say something else, but he lunges his foot forward and stomps my hand, crushing my fingers under his immense weight.

"Ahhh! W-why?! Why would you do that?!"

Strengthened by the pain and anger, my voice finally gains enough timbre that I can shout at the False Me.

"Look to the right."

He offers me a simple request. I don't know why he wants this, but I look anyway. I struggle to move my head, but as I turn my attention, my anger washes away. Cassiel lies in a pool of blood. Her wings are torn to ribbons and bones stick out all over. Her body is marred by gashes, breaks, and bruises, and her pure white robes are stained brown from dried blood.

"Now look to the other side."

My neck screams against the effort, but I quickly spin my head. Samantha lies in pieces, her arms and legs detached from her body, and entrails spilling all over the ground. One colossal stab wound stretching from her neck to her stomach is visible, as if a giant sword had impaled her in a single motion.

I feel queasy. "I didn't kill them. You did! Who are you?!"

A scrunching noise. The other me kneels down slowly, deliberately.

"I'm you, but without the lies. We're both killers. You just won't admit it, '*Hero*'."

He's wrong... he must be wrong. I could never hurt them.

"Ah-ah-ah." He wiggles his finger back and forth chidingly. "I see the gears turning. You can't justify being a murderer. You've killed plenty of demons before," He gestures to Samantha, "so what's one more?"

"You're wrong! It's not the same!"

My retort doesn't stop him. He reaches behind himself and pulls out a craftsman's hammer, then lunges forward and pounds me in the back with it, smashing my ribcage to pieces. My weak wheeze of pain doesn't daunt him at all.

"That's exactly what a monster would say."

* * *

It was just a dream. It was just a dream. It was just a dream.

I quickly wipe the sweat from my forehead and stare at the ceiling above. It's the same dream as the one I had before we discovered the spaceship. I forgot about that one before, but now I remember every detail. Cassiel and Samantha both died in my dream. Why? Am I dreaming such things because I want that to happen?! No- the thought is absurd. I never want anything bad to happen to them. Cassiel is a kind, warmhearted woman. Samantha has a playful streak, but she cares deeply for me as well.

Still, the words... I said those words to myself. I wasn't wrong. I've killed thousands, possibly millions of demons. Samantha is the Second Emperor of the demons. She hates me.

No! She- she doesn't! If she hated me, how could she bear to smile so lovingly? How could she resist scowling or glaring every so often? She's never expressed even the remotest bit of disgust toward me.

It's just a dream in the end.

I move my arms around, then realize I'm alone. Usually, the girls would be here- didn't they sleep with me last night? What if-

I move to pull the covers off but blink in surprise. I'm not on the bed. I'm ten feet away, on the cold steel floor. How the fuck did I get here? Whatever. I jump to my feet and inhale, sensing the aura of power ripple from my body. The sickening feeling of weakness was just part of the dream, after all. There's nothing more to it. Pulling pants and a shirt on, I step through the automatic doorway, just in time to see Samantha rounding a corner. I immediately breathe easier, until I notice the worried expression on her face.

"Hero! You're awake? I was just coming to tell you- well, that is, something happened while you were asleep."

"Uh... uh huh." I nod dumbly. "What happened?"

The look on her face is starting to worry me. "It's Cassiel. There was an accident. She was checking on the robots in the rear armory-"

My heart pounds in my chest. "Is she okay?!" I lunge forward and grab Samantha's shoulders, my blood turning to ice the whole time. "Where is she?!"

Samantha looks at me in confusion. "Promise me you won't get mad, okay?"

"Get mad??" I'm on the edge of sanity at this point. "Is she alive? Comatose?!"

Samantha narrows her eyes. "... Yes. She was in the armory, something made her sneeze, and she destroyed the rear section of the ship. She blew out five of the nine engines and violently ejected us from hyperspace. I thought that's what woke you up." Samantha pulls away from my grasp and raises an eyebrow. "Are you okay? You're not going to flip out or anything, are you?"

I'm so confused. "Yes. I am fine." The words come out stiffly, "Where is Cassiel now?"

Samantha shrugs. "She's outside, flying around the ship, trying to fix the damage. I think."

"She's outside? In the vacuum of outer space?"

"Yup."

"Is she okay?"

"Yup."

"How?"

"Dunno."

Samantha, as always, is completely unhelpful at times like this. And just as I have that thought, from around the corner Cassiel steps out and sees the two of us. Her pure white robes

are smudged brown and black, torn in various spots, and even her feathers are filthy. "Oh, um, hi! I guess Sammy told you what happened."

I continue to nod dumbly. "You broke the ship or something. I got the gist of it. Also, you were outside the ship...?"

She nods excitedly. "It's awesome! I guess I never really thought about it before since I was born a human, but angels don't need to breathe! We can fly around in outer space just fine!"

My blood pressure finally begins to lower. "That's good news, Cass." I wipe more sweat from my forehead. "I had an awful dream again. I woke up and wasn't sure of what was going on. I guess now I know how I ended up on the floor."

Samantha nods slowly, "Yeah, you were acting weird for a minute. Are you feeling better?"

The look of concern on her face makes me feel a little guilty. *Better not go into detail*, my brain whispers. "Yeah. I'll fix the ship now."

She sighs but otherwise assumes everything is normal again. "Wonderful. Let's jump in space suits and inspect the damage."

A few minutes later, Samantha and I enter the Docking Bay. The three suits on the wall are copies I made from the ship's computers, and are very slender and form-fitting, unlike the space-suits I remember from my youth. I aim my mind at one of the suits. "**Wear.**"

The suit vanishes from the wall, appearing on top of Samantha instantly. Her cute little tail pokes out from a hole I left on the back, which is vacuum-sealed immediately. The tight material closes over her figure and creates a seductive bodysuit that accentuates all of her best curves.

Samantha reaches for a helmet, but stops when she spots me staring. "Oh come on, I'm wearing more clothing than usual and *now* you're aroused?"

She isn't wrong, but... "Samantha, I have to ask you something serious."

"Oh?" Her flirty tone flatlines into something more like curiosity. "And what's that?"

How do I phrase a question like this?

"I've, uh- well, I've killed a lot of demons, you know."

She stares silently for a few moments. "Right."

"Doesn't that bother you? I mean, haven't you ever thought about all the demons I've killed?"

She looks away and stares at the helmet on the wall. "Of course. It's not a big deal."

The discomfort in the air is palpable. She won't even look at my eyes. "How can you say it's no big deal? What if I've killed friends of yours? Family? How could you honestly ever look at

me and feel anything other than anger?"

"I don't know." She keeps looking away, "Maybe I just feel a bit guilty."

"Guilty?"

"Sure." Finally, she looks back at me, and her expression is more somber than I've ever seen her before. "How many demons do you think you've killed? Thousands? Millions? I'm the second most powerful of my kind, and I never tried to stop my people from killing humans and angels. I bear some of that responsibility too."

My mind immediately asks, *so we're both murderers, in a way?*

"That's different, though. I killed many demons personally, with my bare hands. Nobody would fault you for the actions of others. Maybe you should have spoken up, but it's not the same as killing humans direc-"

"I have killed humans!" Samantha lashes out suddenly, a look of anger on her face. Her rapid transformation makes me take a step back. "Don't you know what a succubus is?! We take the essence of men and convert it to life force for ourselves to live on! Satan was the only demon stronger than me, so it meant he had plenty left over. But what do you think I had to do after Satan left?!"

A strange roiling churns in my stomach. "You- you killed human men?"

Samantha wrings her hands together nervously. "Well, yes! You may not realize this because you're an *abnormal* human, but most men lose their sense of reason in the presence of a succubus. I don't kill them deliberately, you know. They just- they just die afterward!"

Both of us stare at each other for a few moments before looking away. "Sorry. I didn't realize."

Samantha looks back at me again, this time with calm in her eyes. "Why do you think I went to Hero City? I assumed I would have plenty of men around. I couldn't believe my luck when I sensed your energy level. I didn't have to kill anyone anymore."

A red flag raises in the back of my animal brain. "Wait, are you saying you pursued me just because I was overflowing with energy? Is that the reason?"

She reaches up and strings a finger through her hair, then leans against a wall stiffly. "At first. You were also fun, of course, and your ability is very interesting, but I began to see over the short time we've spent together that you're a good, honest man. You've done awful things, but you want to right your wrongs. I've never been with a man like that before. I've only ever been with- been with killers."

"Sounds like nothing's changed."

Despite my grim tone, I chuckle to myself. *So it was like that, huh?* I'm getting bent out of shape thinking about how terrible I am, but she's awful too. "I guess we're right for each other."

Finally, a smile. She slinks over to me and rubs my chest softly. "I'm always here for you, love. It's better that we're being more honest with each other anyway, don't you think?"

I pull her in and kiss her long and tenderly. Her lips are soft, and the taste is sweet like honey, as always. "Yeah. Let's get back to work."

She pulls away from me and grabs her helmet off the wall. "You know, on the topic of you being an odd one... did you know you're the first man, human or demon, who is unaffected by my succubi aura?"

Talking about past boyfriends is always a way to bring down the mood, my heart sighs. On the other hand, I perk up slightly at the thought that I'm special. "Really? What about Satan?"

She shakes her head and her hair flits around softly. "No, even he was always entranced by my aura. It had a lesser effect on him compared to most others, but unless you're just good at hiding how enamored you are, you're immune."

"Huh. Neat." I don't know what else to say, so I set the helmet on my head and walk along down the aisles with her until we arrive at the force-field airlock leading to outer space. Once our communicators come online, Cassiel's voice sounds off in my headset. "Finally! You two took forever! Are you ready to have a look?"

Sorry, Cass. It was important. "Yeah. Aren't you joining us?"

"Don't be silly. I may be able to fly around in space like it doesn't matter, but in the vacuum, I can't talk at all."

"You could put on a space-suit," Samantha offers helpfully.

I can almost hear Cassiel's eyes rolling. "No way! I'd feel so cramped, and my wings would have the circulation cut off, ugh!"

"You have a point." Samantha reaches around and rubs her butt, a sad expression passing over her face. "I can barely feel my devil-damned tail in this thing. If it falls off, will you Wordsmith it back on?"

"Sure," I snicker to myself, "let me know if your butt gets sore too. I'll give it a rub."

"Funny."

A minute later, we hop through the force-field, which allows anything to pass but gaseous material, to preserve the oxygen inside, and I think of an idea as I'm trying to maneuver around

all the objects floating in midair with the suit's flight controls. They're somewhat intuitive, but they simply feel clunky to me. " **Flight.** "

Immediately, I feel an invisible force wash over me, allowing me to control my movements with just my mind. Samantha spots my accelerated movements and scowls at me. "Hey! No fair!"

After I give her the power of flight, the two of us exit out the rear of the ship, and I stare at the gaping hole. "Wow, Cass. You did a number back here."

"Sorry." Her apologetic tone doesn't make me feel any better.

"Where are all the micro-dreadnoughts? Wasn't this ship equipped with a small contingent for defensive purposes? The missiles are gone, too."

Samantha glides over to me, "Like I said, we were traveling at Warp Seven. We exited hyperspace a second or two later, but the damage was already done. They're probably scattered to the far reaches of space by now, assuming they're even intact."

Assuming they're intact? "Cass, just how hard did you sneeze? This level of destruction is ridiculous."

"I said I'm sorry!" I can almost hear the pouting tone in her voice. "That was the first time I've sneezed since I died, I'll have you know. It's not like I'd want to break all the robots."

"Yeah, *no kidding*," Samantha intones blandly, "you'd sooner kill yourself than dent a walking tin can."

Kill yourself.

Kill yourself.

Samantha's words ring in my ears. I shake my head to fight off a sudden feeling of unease. "Forget it. I'll fix the ship, and we'll be on our way. How long until we reach Earth?"

"A couple of weeks," Cassiel says, "it's over 16,000 light years from where we started, but warp speed is truly something!"

"You don't say."

At times like this, I'm glad I have Cassiel. She was born long after I sealed myself in the Cryopod, and she knows how technology created during the Energy Wars works. Samantha, on the other hand, knows about the state of the modern-day galaxy, or modern era, given how long it's been. Sometimes it still boggles my mind.

A hundred million years. What a ludicrous amount of time.

" **Storage.** " With a single word, my mental storage opens up, and I quickly grab for the Crown of Solomon, only to pause for a moment. A familiar grey orb sits in a corner, untouched. Hoarhiim's orb. A close friend and mentor. He gave his life to save mine because he believed I was destined for great things. Was he right? Was he wrong?

Will I ever know the answer?

I gently rub his orb before grabbing the Crown out, closing the void, and reaching deep within myself. For the second time since discovering the ship, I imagine every processor, every hallway, the giant boosters on the back, and even smaller details like a faded painting one of the crew had hung in the armory. Condensing all of my mental power together, I focus my energy into a single word. " **Rebuild!** "

A minute later, the ship shines and glimmers, as all jagged edges have been magically polished and repaired, and the ship's rear has been reconstructed from the ground up.

"Impressive as always, love." Samantha rubs her tail again. "Mind if we take the shorter route inside? It's only been a few minutes, and I can't wait to get this suit off."

"Funny, I was thinking the same thing."

Samantha and Cassiel both groan in unison. "Oh, you! You're such a perv sometimes!"

" **Teleport!** "

* * *

Diablo, the Third Emperor of Hell, one of the mightiest demons of all time, a demon whose power causes other to tremble in his wake, bows meekly before the delegates. All four hundred and sixteen of them eye him with a mixture of dissatisfaction and disgust.

"The human has left the Labyrinth? Why now, of all times? Why did you wait so long to inform us of this news?" A nasally Volgrim councilor, Elder Basil, snuffles quietly after every sentence. His grating voice and the way he always looks down on those around him makes him a generally disliked member of the Council of Founders, but his connections give him significant pull when it comes time to vote. "Am I to infer that you might even be working with that one?"

Diablo raises his head back up and uses all his willpower to hold back a glare of contempt for the overweight, sniveling alien. "Certainly not, Elder Basil. That was never my intention. As you may well know, it takes time to travel through the registered portals and to seek an audience with such important and busy Volgrim, such as yourselves."

The Third Emperor tries not to snicker at his obvious sarcasm, but it can't be helped if a little bit slips out. The Volgrim, being such an unemotional species, cannot tell sarcasm from serious

statements. It was the only way he could rebel against such a powerful adversary, even if it was a tiny resistance that would hold no lasting impact.

In a room like this, where the Volgrim Elders deliberate, all of whom have lived since the Energy Wars and whose decisions impact demons on a daily basis, the room is one that always awes the Third Emperor. It's a giant coliseum of sorts, with ten ascending rows where the more important Volgrim sit up front, while the newest Elders sit in the rear. All of them are seated in a U-shape so they can see and speak to each other easily, while also allowing them to talk to outsiders in the center of the room, from time to time. The pure white metallic walls and sterile environment remind Diablo of the bland personalities of each member of the hivemind.

A female Elder in the second row speaks next. Diablo doesn't recognize her, but she seems influential, judging by the garb she wears. "If he has left the dimension of the Labyrinth, and he is traveling in Type 1 space, this poses a grave danger to Volgrim and Demonkind alike. The power of a Hero was thought extinct until that human reappeared. You assured us he was contained to the Labyrinth, yet now you expect us to do something about him, all while we fight off the Kolvaxian scourge? Did you not think of how pervasive this new menace was before we were forced to divert essential resources to put an end to the human?"

Diablo shakes his head slowly and puts on his best impression of mock sadness. "I am sorry, delegates. As I reported, he is traveling with the Second Emperor, and she is far stronger than I. If the eight Emperors and Generals directly under her combined our forces, we could not hope to defeat her, let alone the human and the angel as well."

Elder Basil leans forward, his disgusting fat belly poking through the folds of his tight robes, as a look of disgust washes over his face. "Excuses. Is that all you have? What are we to think when this human is joined by the second most powerful of your species, hmm? Obviously, some form of collusion is to be expected. We know how you demons long to be out from under our control, but that is not going to happen. A demon, human, or angel left unattended always turns to thralldom and war when given the opportunity."

The female from earlier makes a motion to another Volgrim across from her. "Elder Kryios, what do you think of the appearance of this angel? Isn't the timing coincidental?"

Kryios, one of the longest-serving members of the Council, gently strokes her long white hair, keeping her eyes closed as she sits deep in thought. "Yes. The demons told us that all angels were killed during the Energy Wars, yet a hero and an angel are joined by one of the Demon Emperors. If I were a gambler, I would hedge my bets that the demons planned this."

"Planned it? That's absurd! We've lost millions of my people to this human! In fact, we've-!" Diablo stops his rant quickly, realizing that the eyes of all the Volgrim are upon him. *One wrong*

word and they can summon an army to eliminate me. Best not be too boisterous. "I beg your pardon. I didn't mean to lose my cool."

To his relief, none of the councilors seem to care. Elder Basil raps his fingers lightly on his legs. "If you are not lying, and the demons have no treachery in their hearts, then you must stop the Hero from achieving whatever genocidal goals he is likely pursuing. Speak to your First Emperor, and be sure he is involved as well. If he is the only demon powerful enough to stop the Second, then obviously he should do so."

Diablo's hands clam up. Until now, he had been feeling mildly awed and perhaps even a little worried, but at the mention of the *First Emperor*, he begins to sweat profusely. "Y-you want me to order the First to assist us? That's asking for a lot of trouble."

Elder Kryios waves a hand flippantly. "Yes, yes, the ever-reclusive First Emperor. You've regaled us with frightening stories of his supposed power, but considering he's too afraid to even step into the light of day, I can't say I'm anything but unimpressed by him. Perhaps if he stepped out of the shadows and did a little dirty work, he could keep a collar on the Second and prevent her from striking off on merry adventures with a *human*." Kryios spits the last word out. "What terrible ethics she has."

Diablo clamps his hands together to steady the shaking. "Of- of course. As you wish. I will see if I can get the First to-"

"Begone, then." Elder Basil makes a *shoo* motion with his hands. "We've held off war tactics regarding the Kolvaxians just to hear you prattle. Go be useful and leave our sight."

The Third Emperor nods quickly and shuffles out of the room, passing a massive metal war machine that scans him silently.

As the door closes behind him, he curses under his breath, "Bastards. The First will make them pay for their mockery."

Part 432c: Dead Space

"Why are we going to Earth anyway?" Samantha leans against the wall in the lounge, standing on her hands and stretching her legs up to touch her toes to the wall, before gently kicking away from it and walking around on her palms. "It's a dead planet. There's nothing to see."

Cassiel watches Samantha with only the slightest interest in her daily exercising, while she lightly tosses a red ball from one hand to the other. "Well, Hero was frozen for all those years. Maybe he just wants to find out what it's like after all this time? I'm a little curious myself."

I ignore the fact they're talking about me like I'm not even here, and take another slurp of my beef wonton soup. It reminds me of a time before the labyrinth and hell became a part of my life, and it feels somewhat comforting. "I just have an odd hunch. I think I'm supposed to meet someone there."

Samantha raises one arm out and away from her body, then gently lifts herself into the air on a single finger before spreading her legs wide open. It's a feat of incredible contortion that I can only assume is possible due to her demonic power. "How? Earth is inhospitable to life, now. It doesn't have an atmosphere anymore. No air to breathe, no water, nothing."

"Wow. What happened to ruin the planet?" Cassiel, always the curious one, blurts the question out. Her eyes raise up to the metal ceiling in thought, and she spins around in her chair slowly. "Boiling away the entire atmosphere is crazy."

Apparently hearing her question, the door slides open and OMEN walks in the room. We've been traveling for three weeks on this ship, and I'm still not used to the way he pops up at random times. I suspect he has full access to the ship's internal communications, but it's been more of a help than a hindrance.

"Response: Data regarding Earth's demise is classified at the highest levels. Only the leader of the United Earth Federation may access this information. It is encrypted with a four-layered deadman's switch, an incorrect response to which will cause the data's self-destruction, along with all other information aboard this vessel. Query: Would you like to attempt to access this information?"

Cassiel stares at the robot for all of two seconds. "No. That would be dumb to even try."

Samantha launches herself into the air with her single finger, landing perfectly on both feet like a world-class gymnast. "Nobody knows. It's just one of those things missing from our memories."

I shift uncomfortably in my seat. "What do you mean? That's a little strange. Why wouldn't anyone remember the destruction of a goddamn planet? That seems like something you'd never be able to forget, not even in a hundred million years."

A shrug. Samantha walks over and plops in my lap, then lays back on me. "It's just one of those things, love. All information regarding Earth's destruction vanished. Well, the planet is still there, technically. It's just a hunk of dead rock now. We just don't know how the Volgrim destroyed it."

"Awful convenient, if you ask me." Cassiel stops spinning around in her chair, and I can almost see the lightbulb appear over her head. "I'll bet the Volgrim hid the evidence! Mass brainwashing! My mother and father said they were a highly advanced species."

"Maaaybe." Samantha is unconvinced. "I spent thousands of years looking into it before losing interest. I'm unconvinced the Volgrim had the tech to pull something off like that, nor why they'd want to hide it."

Since I don't have any opinion about something I wasn't there to witness, I keep quiet and wrap my arms around Samantha, contemplating all this Volgrim and memory wiping nonsense. If these aliens have firm control over the Labyrinth, and the demons control the humans above them, then I guess if the Volgrim had memory wiping machines they could mass brainwash everyone, or at least everyone who knew, but it does seem like a lot of work. Especially given they already won the war, or whatever.

OMEN chirps in again, always willing to interrupt conversations as he pleases. "Notification: We are within three lightyears of the Terran system. We will be arriving in fifteen minutes. Do you wish to keep the ship in autopilot mode until we arrive?"

Cassiel immediately leaps from her chair and smiles a big grin. "Finally! I'll take over once we arrive. Stop us just outside Neptune's orbit." We'll approach the inner solar system at Warp 1.4 and maintain alert status."

Samantha pulls away from me and walks over to the door. "I still think this is pointless, but I admit I'm curious. I haven't seen Earth in, well, millions of years. The Labyrinth has been quite boring."

All three of us exit and start walking down the sterile hallways and up toward the bridge. "I miss the feeling of grass, and the smell of fresh air," Cassiel says, "but mostly I miss seeing ducks and cats and dogs. I haven't seen animals in, well, an eternity."

Why did she list ducks first? My brain asks a dumb question, but I ignore it. "If you want, I can create some animals, you know. I did so on that Volgarius planet. Heck, if Earth is dead, I can remake it again. Easy peasy."

Her embarrassed smile lights up my day. "Really?! You'd do that for me?"

"Yup. Actually, I just want to, period. Humanity needs a home, so why not remake life on our original planet? We can't let these 'Volgrim' run our lives forever."

Samantha seems visibly uncomfortable as we step onto the bridge. "Resisting the Volgrim is a losing endeavor, in my opinion. Their weapons can tear apart demons easily because they target magical energy. Hell, even the robots on this ship could have done the same... until Cassiel blasted them to kingdom come."

"Sorry." Cassiel winces, and all three of us take up our seating positions. "It was an accident."

"I know. It's not your fault. Still, those machines were quite powerful. I was uncomfortable having them so close. They made me... uneasy."

The two of them continue back and forth for several minutes, Cassiel teasing Samantha about her dislike of robots, while Samantha jabs back with 'tin-can lover' and some other silly things, until OMEN interrupts them. "Notification: We will be arriving in Terran space within thirty seconds."

The jovial atmosphere turns tense. A feeling of suspense fills the air as the timer ticks down.

Terran space. Earth. The Solar System. Whatever one wants to call it, it was a home to all three of us at one point. The fact I'm arriving in such a distant future means I'm going to see something unthinkable to humans from my time. Even Cassiel, who died before Earth's destruction, has no idea what we're going to find.

"A pet duck would be neat," Cassiel mumbles under her breath. What a weird thing to say now, of all times.

OMEN's lifeless face stays rigid as the timer counts down. "Notification: Arriving in Terran space in five, four, three, two, one..."

The ship exits hyperspace dramatically, going from Warp Seven to a standstill so quickly that I half expect to fly out of my seat and face-plant against the wall, but the inertia dampeners keep that from happening.

The viewscreen changes to show space around us. Nothing is out of the ordinary, or very interesting, for that matter. Way in the distance, a tiny luminous speck signals the Sun, in all of its glory. From this far away, it hardly looks like the ball of gas that I remember.

"The sun is tiny." Cassiel echoes my thoughts, "I've never seen it from this distance before. My mother and father always promised to take me on a trip to Mars, but I never had the time to leave."

Samantha flops back heavily in her chair. "Well, let's move closer."

"Sure." Cassiel taps a few buttons and activates the thrusters once again, this time moving us to just over Warp 1. "Normally it would take several hours to reach Earth at lightspeed, but we'll get there in ten minutes or so at this speed. Wanna stop and look at planets along the way? Jupiter is on the opposite side of the system, but, erm, Uranus is fairly close."

A stupid smile crosses my face. "I'll bet it is."

Samantha *snrks* to herself. "You couldn't help yourself, could you?"

"I'm just a guy."

The ship cruises forward, and within a minute, we slow to a stop as the giant blue planet appears in front of us. I feel my hands tremble slightly at the sight. Emotion fills me that is difficult to put into words. *I'm looking at a planet that nobody from my time had ever seen before, not with this level of detail. Scientists would have killed for a chance to be this close, and I'm here now.*

It's an awe-inspiring feeling. In the end, humanity was all but wiped out, yet I still live on, trying to put the pieces back together.

Cassiel stares silently for several long moments at the shimmering gasses swirling on the planet below. The ship's sensors enhance our viewing ability since otherwise the planet's features aren't illuminated enough by the distant sun to be distinguishable to the human eye. "It's pretty."

Even Samantha eyes it with interest. "I've been alive for tens of millions of years, and I've never seen this world before. It's a beautiful view."

After a few minutes, Cassiel turns back to her controls. "Let's keep moving. Mars is next, then Earth."

"What about Saturn?" I look at her quizzically, and she shrugs.

"It's a little out of the way. We can look later, unless you wanna make a detour now?"

"No, that's alright. Let's keep going." These planets are interesting, but the thought of seeing Earth again makes me feel unbelievably anxious. *There's something waiting for me*, my mind whispers. I don't know what it is, but Earth has a piece of the puzzle. I have to find out whatever it is.

The ship accelerates, and Cassiel leaves Neptune behind us. All the while, my heartbeat quickens. *The nightmares lately won't stop. Nothing makes them go away, not even my wordsmithing. It's as if there's something inside me linking to knowledge of another time, another life. I know things I shouldn't. I knew what OMEN was before I spoke to him. I knew*

how to respond. These nightmares aren't just paranoia in the back of my mind. They must be a warning of some kind. But why are they always about the girls dying?

I have so many questions. I've done this before, but *differently*. It's the same, yet not.

My internal questions are cut off as OMEN once again pipes up. "Yellow level alert: I am detecting spacecraft on the long-range scanners. The transmission signals intercepted are Volgrim in origin, with a 98% confidence level."

Cassiel's breath catches as she taps a button with lightning speed. The ship immediately slows down, and she quickly presses several more buttons. "I'm running a detailed scan."

Samantha and I shoot a look of alarm at each other before Cassiel delivers the verdict. "Careless. I should have checked sooner. I just scanned Mars... it has a massive network of cities built on its surface. The Volgrim live there now." For the first time I've seen, a look of disgust and rage is evident on her face. "I can't believe it. Bastards. They killed us, then took over our home?!"

Visibly shaken, Samantha looks at me again. "We should leave. We don't stand a chance against an armada of Volgrim warships."

Cassiel's rage falters and is replaced by a pale expression of fear. "There are thousands of them. Why didn't we detect them sooner? They-"

She's interrupted by the bridge's AI. "Incoming hail. Response?"

"Devil-damned." Samantha jerks in her seat. "They saw us. We can still flee."

I, for one, feel more annoyed than anything. "No. Let's hear what these aliens have to say. Maybe I can finally get some answers."

Cassiel nods reluctantly and taps another button. The main viewscreen shifts a moment later to reveal what my initial instincts tell me is a human. A man, young looking, with a blank expression on his face, stares at us for a few seconds, his eyes sweeping from Cassiel, to me, to Samantha. His white uniform is decidedly military, with a single star visible on the lapel. His black hair is cleanly slicked back, and he looks otherwise bored by our vessel. It's only when he opens his mouth to speak that I'm jarred by the realization that he's not human at all.

"Unknown vessel, what is your identifier? We are not expecting any new arrivals to this system for several cycles." His mouth is filled with shark-like teeth, and his words are translated by our ship's communicator a second after he speaks in his language. It's a little jarring, but I'm able to get used to it within moments. He glances away at something offscreen before looking back, this time with a puzzled expression. "Your ship design does not conform to any known specifications. Additionally..." He pauses again, and this time reaches up to his ear, as if

listening to a hidden piece for instructions. "...I have detected only three life signs aboard your vessel. Who are you?"

I can see him putting the pieces together rapidly. *Go big or go home*, my mind says to me.

"I am Jason Hiro, commander of this vessel. I've come to investigate the Terran system and to, uh, see what's up."

Cassiel groans audibly and smacks her forehead. I suddenly realize how stupid I just sounded.

The Volgrim male onscreen's eyes widen, having probably noticed my teeth don't look anything like his. "A human? It can't be." His voice fills with urgency. "You will surrender your vessel to our authorities at once. Any attempt to flee or any hostile actions will be met with deadly force. You will be apprehended, as per the Human Limitation Act."

Samantha quickly turns to look at me, fear in her eyes. *Not good!*

I don't know what to do. I didn't expect the Volgrim to be here, though in hindsight it should have been obvious. Several options cross my mind. *I could destroy their fleet with wordsmithing. I could fabricate the Trifrancium needed to allow us to escape at Warp 10, and Cassiel can give me enough energy to create a large enough quantity that the fleet couldn't possibly catch up to us. Hell, I could even teleport this ship back to Volgarius. I already wordsmithed a relay there, just in case.*

Perhaps seeing the indecision on my face, Samantha decides to try something. She turns back to the video. "Don't. If you attack us, we will annihilate you. We have a Sentinel under our control."

The look of confidence on the Volgrim's face tightens. "Unlikely. The Sentinels have long since been eradicated. If you attempt to resist, we will annihilate you. Humans and angels are not afforded any protections under the guidelines established during the First Era."

Samantha doesn't respond. Instead, she looks at Cassiel and nods. Cassiel, apparently hearing some telepathic communication or via weird girl-vooodoo I can't understand, knows exactly what Samantha wants. She taps a few buttons, and the screen shifts again, this time showing the Volgrim on the left side of the screen, and an image of Ionis in the cargo bay, standing stiffly at attention, his lone eye staring forward emotionlessly.

"I'm not kidding," Samantha says, "if you attack, we'll activate it."

Instantly, the young Volgrim's smug aura vanishes. His face whitens, though he tries his best to hide it. "Y-you're bluffing. That isn't poss-"

The feed cuts off, and his face is replaced by a different one. This time, the Volgrim in question looks substantially older. Her face is rigid, and her jawline is set, as if she's trying to look tough, but uncertain how we perceive her. "Belial, second Emperor of the Demons. It's been a while."

Cassiel taps a button and a small part of the screen changes, showing several dots converging on our location. She doesn't say anything, but I understand what she's implying. *Time is running out.*

Samantha, apparently feeling less anxious, smiles at the woman onscreen. "Elder Kryios. Why would one of the highest ranked leaders of Volgrim-kind be here, of all places?"

The Volgrim doesn't flinch. "I'm asking the questions. Why do you have a Sentinel in your possession? That should be impossible."

"*Should* be?" Samantha leans forward and puts on her best innocent fake smile. "You know, that statement doesn't sound very confident. Shall we activate him? Ionis is *very good* at following orders. He doesn't like Volgrim either, from what he's told us."

A bald-faced lie. The thing hasn't said a single word to us since it arrived, and I've poked and prodded it a few times, as has Cassiel. It just stands in the cargo hold, staring ahead, silently. I doubt it would save us if we begged it to with all our hearts.

Elder Kryios, however, is now visibly unnerved. "They- they didn't say you would have a Sentinel. Ludicrous. Why have you come here?"

"We just wanted to look around. You're not going to stop us from having a peek, are you? Can't some old friends check out the sights once in a while?"

My arm-console silently blinks a warning. The ships are closing in. Less than a minute away, by the looks of it.

The aged Volgrim gnashes her teeth. "This is a restricted zone. Nobody, and certainly not a human, is allowed to enter this system. I should kill you for daring to trespass."

Samantha leans back in her chair and crosses her legs. "Okay, that's fine. I'm sure you can blow this ship up and possibly kill the three of us, but do you have anything that can defeat a Sentinel? Even the slightest glimmer of hope?"

Kryios looks away for a moment at something offscreen, before turning back. "This will have repercussions. We were considering the three of you a rogue element, but now you are enemies of the collective. You would be wise to surrender."

Samantha widens her eyes in mock surprise. "So you *do* have a way to destroy a Sentinel! That explains your confidence!"

"No." Kryios taps a button on her side. "We do not. Nobody does. Bringing one of those horrors with you... you must have a death wish."

The dots approaching our ship slow to a stop, and then begin reversing course. "The Council doesn't have time to deal with your petty foolishness. Have a look around, then. It doesn't matter. Once I get the backup needed, you will not leave alive with anything you've learned."

The feed cuts off, and seconds later, Samantha's smile vanishes. "Devil's sake." Her hands start shaking, and she turns to me. "We're in a hell of a lot of trouble, Hero."

"That was very brave of you, Sammy." Cassiel smiles weakly at the succubus, but it feels half-hearted. The dots continue to leave, and soon they're completely offscreen. "I can't believe that worked."

"It hardly matters. Weren't you listening? The Council must have been observing our movements. I think they knew we were coming." Samantha climbs out of her chair and walks over to plop down next to me. "I hate the Volgrim. They think only according to efficiency and how to maximize output. Everything is just a tool for them to use. They even designed the systems for keeping humans contained."

Cassiel taps on her console again and accelerates our ship toward Earth. Then she walks over and sits next to me on my other side. "What is the Council? That creepy Kreedos lady mentioned them like they were important."

" *Kryios*. " Samantha corrects Cassiel, "I'm not very familiar with the Volgrim hierarchy, especially since I mostly ignore political goings-on. Still, I remember the early days following the conclusion of the Energy Wars. Elder Kryios was one of the remaining upper-ranked Volgrim, pending the destruction of the Founders. She and many others, a few hundred as I recall, decided to try a new system of governance. I believe she wields much influence now, though I can't say for certain."

I nod along at her explanation, but political stuff bores me almost as much as it does her. "She sounds like a nasty alien. Well, they all do. I'll have to be a lot more careful."

"No kidding." Cassiel chuckles wryly, "Anyway, what's done is done. If they attack us, we'll fight back. And it seems Sammy hit a nerve! They're terrified of Ionis."

Samantha doesn't return the enthusiasm. "We all should be. I would have been delighted to learn all the Sentinels were disassembled. They probably have to convene an emergency meeting to deal with the threat we just showed them. We're far from out of the woods."

Both girls sigh and lean against me, almost in unison. I pull them both in close and feel the tension melt away. They mean everything to me right now. I can't be so careless when their lives

are at stake, not like what I just did. I have to be more cautious.

I took a risk, challenging the Volgrim. It wasn't even me who saved the day, but Samantha. Her knowledge of the world is the only thing that prevented us from being blown out of the sky. Well, that, but I also could have teleported us any time I wanted. Come to think of it; maybe the risk wasn't as bad as I thought.

The three of us wait silently, deep in thought, as the minutes tick by. Soon, the bridge AI speaks.

"Destination approaching. Dropping out of warp space in three... two... one..."

Once again, the stars melt away and the ship comes to a halt, and this time all three of us stare in stunned silence.

It's Earth. But not the one I know.

The entire planet is encased in colossal sheets of glacial ice. The greens and blues and whites and yellows and orange hues that I remember from photographs of my planet, taken by NASA, are nowhere to be seen. The entire thing is a hunk of frost, floating in the void.

Cassiel takes several seconds before she can pull her jaw up and stop gaping at the sight. Hesitantly, she walks over to her navigation chair and inputs a command. "I'm... I'm running a scan."

Samantha and I continue holding each other's hand while we wait for the verdict. Cassiel's tone is nearly as icy as the dead sphere before us. "The atmosphere is almost entirely gone. The planet has ice made of methane and hydrogen wrapping around every inch of it. I can't detect any life at all, though I guess we expected-" She pauses suddenly, before shooting Samantha a quizzical look of disbelief. "Sammy, where the fuck is the Moon?"

It's the first time I've heard her curse. Her sudden outburst makes me curious too. "Computer, where is the Moon?"

The droll male voice in the ceiling sounds bored by my question. "Unknown."

Cassiel shakes her head slowly before returning to looking at her display readout. "Well, if the Moon isn't here, that explains all the weird stuff that's going on."

"Weird stuff?" Samantha offers a gentle verbal nudge. "Like what?"

The angelic girl scratches her head as she examines the readouts. "Well, the planet is rotating at a ridiculous speed. It's about eight hours for an Earth 'day' now, not twenty-four. The orbit is a significant deviation from what it should be, and Earth is spinning completely on its side. The North Pole is facing the Sun directly, and the South Pole is opposite. Also, for some reason, the Earth doesn't have a magnetic field surrounding it anymore. If that's the case..."

"...the molten core is no longer molten?" I finish her sentence for her, and she nods.

"Probably. What did those alien bastards do? They ruined it completely. The damage is irreparable!"

Samantha shakes her head and sighs, pulling away from me. "It wasn't like this in the distant past, when I last saw it. The entire planet was a lava-covered hellscape. The last time I saw it, thousands of years later, it had cooled into an ugly brown rock, though I don't know what happened after that. I'm not a geologist, after all, I'm just a woman with simple tastes."

Cassiel looks at Samantha curiously. "How did you get to see Earth anyway? From space, I mean."

"It was part of the war conclusion pact. The Volgrim didn't like or trust humans, but there was a mutual understanding between them and us. I just asked if I could see Earth, and as the Second Emperor, they agreed."

"Mutual understanding?" Cassiel echoes the words, "So, you had something to do with Earth's destruction? Not you, but, like, you know... demons in general?"

"I don't know, Cass." Samantha tosses her hands into the air. "I can't remember anything regarding Earth's destruction. However, I wouldn't be surprised if demons did. Perhaps Satan was involved... though I cannot say for sure."

Cassiel nods glumly, "I understand."

The mood is dark, but I decide to take the initiative. I jump to my feet and pull up my sleeves. "Well, I believe the planet is salvageable. It's still home, and I'm going to fix it!"

My cute angel smiles, a bright grin that warms my heart. "You did it for Volgarius! You can do it here too!"

Samantha, however, seems more reserved. "Is it just me, or does the planet have an empty feeling to it? I can't sense anything coming from it, nothing at all."

"I mean, it's a dead rock, so that makes sense." Cassiel's smile turns sardonic as she observes Samantha's expression. "You're not going to sense much from an icy ball floating in the emptiness of space."

"It's more than that," Samantha says, "it's a total void when I reach out to sense it. I didn't get the same feeling from Uranus, and especially not from Mars when we passed it. It's like there's a hole in space itself."

Once again, I start feeling nervous. *A hole in space? That sounds so ridiculous; it stretches the limits of credibility. Yet, at the same time...*

Cassiel's smile vanishes. "Well, when you put it like that, I guess it does feel emptier than the space around it. In fact, the more I think about it, the more that makes sense."

I decide to test something out for myself. " **Detect!** "

Aiming my mind at Earth, I project my wordsmithing at it. What follows next is a flash of pain, impacting me right in the face, as if a giant man with a hammer had just struck me with all his might!

I blink the stars away and feel an awful dizziness, only to realize Samantha and Cassiel are standing over me, terror across their faces. When she sees my eyes open, Cassiel immediately lets out a breath. "Are you okay?"

My head hurts like hell. My face physically aches, as if I broke my cheekbone. "Not really... what happened?"

Samantha's eyes have a sense of urgency to them. "You wordsmithed, and then immediately screamed as if you had been stabbed in the heart, clutched your face, and fell to the ground. You've been out for five minutes!"

I still feel dazed. "Five minutes? Wh-what? It hurt like hell, but it didn't seem that long."

The sound of footsteps approach. To our side, OMEN steps out. I turn to look at his typical expression of total disinterest. "Notation: Supreme Commander Hiro was detected by the ship as having a full mental synapse shutdown for three minutes, thirty-seven seconds. The likelihood that he was able to come back without the aid of a medical droid is unlikely at best."

After a few minutes of the girls babying me, I pull myself to my feet and slump back in my chair. My body hurts like I just ran a 50-mile triathlon in ten minutes. I can barely remember the last time I felt so weak.

Cassiel glares at me. "Stupid! You should have let me run more scans first! Don't be so reckless, Hero!"

"Please... don't yell..." I mumble the words and clutch my head, but the earsplitting pain is taking its sweet time fading away.

Her hardened expression softens, and she walks back over to her seat. "Okay. I think I know what happened. Earth doesn't have a magnetic field, but it does have something else. A ridiculously powerful inverse polaric-energy field."

Her big words just make my head hurt more, and a quick glance at Samantha tells me she doesn't have any idea what that means either. "In English?"

Cassiel sticks a finger in her mouth and chews on a nail gently. "Well, it means the earth is surrounded by anti-energy. It's more energetic than anything I've ever sensed before. This

energy can not only absorb magical energy directed at it, but it can also reflect it. You're lucky you didn't die... for reals."

Samantha reaches over her hand and puts it on mine. "Actually, love, it wasn't luck. Cass saved your life. She's so modest, sometimes."

Her comment is met with a look of embarrassment from Cassiel. "I just tried to use my energy to heal him. It didn't even do anything. He woke up on his own."

Her cute blushing eases my pain a little bit. "No, Cass, you helped me out. You always do."

The three of us smile at each other and share in our relief, until a moment later I jump out of my skin as a terrifying robotic voice speaks into the room, one that wasn't there before.

I HAVE LOCATED ORGANICS ON THE PLANET BELOW. NONE OF THEM BELONG TO THE FOUNDERS. TAKE ME TO THE FOUNDERS.

The terrifyingly loud voice booms in my head, seeming to come from all directions at once, and yet nowhere at all.

The figure steps forward, his lone red eye sweeping across all of us at once, settling his gaze on me.

YOU WILL TAKE ME TO THE FOUNDERS AT ONCE.

Samantha turns from me to the robot standing in the middle of the room. "Oh, fuck me."

Part 433c: I Am Mad Scientist!

YOU WILL TAKE ME TO THE FOUNDERS.

Ionis shines his singular blood red eye on me, staring at me without moving. The Robot stands eight feet tall, a full half head higher than me, and I get the distinct impression he would look down on me even if I were twice his height. His order is final, with no chance for an 'if' or a 'but.' If I don't give him what he wants, he will probably kill me.

However.

"Did you say you detected organic signatures on the planet?" I carefully steel myself and steady my beating heart. Much like facing down a bear in the wild, every instinct inside myself screams at me to not show any weakness. The fact this machine wants me to find the Founders implies it either cannot do so itself, or it has tried and failed. I have leverage.

Ionis swivels its eye toward the viewscreen for a moment, before turning back to me.

AFFIRMATIVE. THERE ARE THREE THOUSAND, SIX HUNDRED AND FORTY-FIVE ORGANIC SIGNATURES ON THE PLANET BELOW. NONE OF THEM BELONG TO THE FOUNDERS. YOU WILL TAKE ME TO WHERE YOU CONCEALED THEM.

I have no idea what he's talking about. Ever since I first met this robot, he's accused me of killing the others of his kind, of hiding these 'founders' away, and even implied I'm not the person I say I am. Probably a glitch, I guess. He has me confused with someone else.

"Supposing I do not take you to the Founders, what will you do about it?"

An immediate response. *I WILL ELIMINATE YOU.*

Cassiel pokes me lightly in my left arm. I glance at her to see an expression of concern. "Um, Hero, are you... talking to Ionis?"

A glance at Belial shows the same question written on her face. "Neither of you two can hear him speaking?"

The girls shake their heads slowly. Somehow, this machine must be communicating with me telepathically.

However, I don't have the time nor luxury to give it much thought. I turn back to the Sentinel. "If you eliminate me, I will not be able to take you to the Founders."

UNACCEPTABLE.

"You can throw a temper tantrum if you want, but it won't change anything. Neither will killing me. I don't know where the Founders are, but I'm perfectly willing to help you find them. You've waited millions of years already, right? What's another day or two?"

The mechanoid stares at me for all of three seconds, an eternity when facing down something that supposedly can eliminate me in the blink of an eye. Finally, he responds.

HOW LONG IS A DAY?

Um, *what*? That wasn't the answer I expected.

"A day is twenty-four hours. There are sixty minutes in an hour, and sixty seconds in a minute. A single second is about this quick-" I pause and snap my fingers to emphasize. "So you shouldn't have to wait long."

The Sentinel's eye swivels again, first to Cassiel, then to Samantha, then back to me.

YOUR BIOLOGY INDICATES YOU ARE GIVING ACCURATE MEASUREMENTS. TWO DAYS.

Oh. I suppose that's that, then. He knows how to tell if humans are lying, but not how long a day is? What a strange murder-bot.

Turning away from the robot slowly, so I don't spook him into a murder spree, I glance at Cassiel. "Ionis says there are almost 4,000 biological lifeforms on the planet below. Can you detect anything?"

Immediately, she gives me a suspicious look. "The Sentinel can detect something like that? From this distance? What, is he scanning for microbes or something?" Still, she shrugs and taps several buttons, then waits several seconds. "I didn't find anything the first time, and I'm not finding anything now. If he detected life signs, they must be miles below the surface."

Miles below the surface.

Her voice echoes in my head.

Underground.

People.

Bunkers.

As though a key clicks into a lock in my brain, I stand up a little straighter. "What prevents us from scanning below the surface?"

Cassiel seems surprised by the question. "I mean, with the right tools I could see all the way into the core, but this ship isn't designed to penetrate a planet's core. It's just supposed to be

able to see through the shields and hull of other starships. If I had something more powerful - much more, at that- then I could scan many miles below the ice and rock."

A simple solution, at last. " **Storage.** " Reaching in, I pull out the Crown of Solomon once more, then aim my mind at the vast blackness of space a great distance from the ship. After several minutes, I can feel my head beginning to swim from all the information needed to construct the device, but eventually, all the pieces click into place. " **SCANNER!** "

Outside, in the silent vacuum of space, a titanic metal device explodes into existence. Ten times the size of our ship, it is created for only one purpose; to scan the deepest recesses of Earth. I stagger back and take a seat, fanning myself as heat flashes course through my blood for several seconds afterward. The strain put on my mind when envisioning such complex machines nearly makes me pass out every time, but if this works, it will be worth it.

I spare a weary glance at Ionis. How did such a small robot, though still taller than me, locate life forms on the planet that our ship scanners couldn't? His technology advancement must be eons greater than humanity's.

Cassiel widens her eyes in surprise. "Oh. So *that's* what you did." She brings the device up on the screen for Samantha to examine and both of them purse their lips in surprise.

Samantha winks at me, "Not bad."

"Yeah. Just... hah... just use the computer to login and scan Earth. See what you can find, Cass." I'm out of breath and exhausted, but thanks to the regenerative powers of the God-King, I feel my second wind coming already.

While Cass types on the ship's console, Samantha glances back at me and her smile falters. "You're bleeding. Are you alright?"

As she says that, I feel wetness on my lips. I quickly realize my nose is bleeding. Summoning that massive device must have taken a decent chunk of my energy, but the real strain was on my mind, not my energy reserves.

" **Heal.** " With a single word, the nosebleed is gone, and coincidentally, so is my fatigue. "Thanks, Sam. I'm fine now."

She nods along but doesn't look as confident as I. Cassiel pulls back and smiles at me. "Hey, how about that! The scanner did the trick! I'm detecting several hundred life signs. They're fuzzy, and I can just barely make them out, but they're definitely under the surface."

I feel a sense of giddy anticipation mixed with dread. "Only a few hundred? Shouldn't there be thousands?"

Cassiel sticks her tongue out at me bashfully. "Teehee, well, you know. That scanner is powerful, but it's still not reliable enough. More importantly, I detected short-range radio waves. Very primitive, meant for close range communication and probably so they won't be detected by... outsiders."

"Us, then." Samantha rubs her arms and strolls over, plopping in my lap. She does that a lot lately. "Are they human?"

Cassiel shrugs. "Maybe. Human and Volgrim are hard to tell apart with such basic life signs. The Volgrim didn't want us near Earth, so it might be them under the surface, but..."

Samantha finishes for her, "But it's more likely they merely don't want anyone finding out what destroyed Earth. If those were Volgrim under the surface, I doubt they would go to such lengths to hide their existence from their own kind."

I lean forward and rest my chin on Samantha's shoulder. "They're probably human. I have this- this weird hunch. A feeling really, probably nothing. I've had these feelings a lot, lately."

Samantha pulls back and leans into me more. "Any chance you'll tell us more, soon?"

She nibbles on my ear playfully, but I pull away and smirk. "Trying to use your charm on me? I'm not even sure what these premonitions mean. I just know they tend to be right." I point a finger at Cass. "Can you communicate with the people on the surface? We can't go onto a planet bathed in such dangerous energy, but we can at least try and talk to them."

A shrug, "It's worth a try. Give me a minute."

I spot a look of jealousy in Cassiel's eye, so I make a mental note that I'll have to give her extra attention tonight. Samantha is just a more aggressive woman who always goes for what she wants.

My gaze raises up to the motionless Sentinel, still standing in the same spot, staring silently at our ship's viewscreen. Not a minute later, Cassiel sighs, "Even that new scanner won't do it. The radio signals under the surface are too weak."

I scratch my nose in thought, before feeling a spark in my mind. "What if we brought one of them up to us? I can't use magical teleportation, but if I dramatically boosted the ship teleporters, we could pull one up here."

Cass seems unsure. "Well, they've been living underground for who knows how long. Assuming the person you bring up is human, they could have an awful disease, or we could give one to them..." She trails off and then smacks her forehead. "Actually, you could cure a problem like that with Wordsmithing. Never mind. It's worth a shot. Who should I pull up?"

I don't have a ready answer for that question. "Just target whoever has the strongest signal, I suppose. We'd ideally want the leader, if one exists, but better to play it safe. We can pull someone up here, then ask them who the leader is and pull them up instead."

You know who the leader is.

A voice speaks to me from my subconscious, but I silently bat it away. Shut up! You can't always be right!

Cassiel takes my suggestion in stride and spends the next few minutes typing in a series of commands, while I give Samantha a shoulder massage. She's very tense, likely due to the robot of annihilation standing silently in front of us, but nobody wants to tell him to go away, so we just have to ignore him. She moans softly every time I hit a tense muscle, and directs me with a finger where things are the worst.

"You're very good at this, love. Have you had practice?"

"Nope. I'm just a natural, I guess."

A little small talk later, Cassiel exhales audibly. "Okay, I found the most likely signal. Powering up the teleporters... now."

Everyone watches silently as shimmering lights appears on the bridge, like a swarm of fireflies, rapidly growing more energetic until they enlarge and form the solid shape of a hunched over figure. A few seconds later, it transforms into a middle-aged woman, perhaps thirty years old, with brown hair and big thick-rimmed glasses. She stumbles forward and lands face-first on the ground. "Ah!"

Cassiel winces, "Oops."

The girl quickly jumps to her feet, panic and terror evident on her face. She's wearing a white lab coat, with an insignia I haven't seen before, comprised of three snakes in a triangular pattern. If I had to make a snap judgment, I'd assume she was a scientist or a lab assistant of some sort.

"Who are you? What's going on?!" The look of panic on her face is starting to make even me feel uneasy.

"Calm down. We're not going to hurt you." I speak gently to her, but at that moment she looks up and spots the Sentinel towering over her, and she immediately falls backwards on her ass and scrambles away from it across the floor. "Hiiiiii! What in the name of god?!" Her shriek of terror sends a chill down my spine. I need to calm her down, and fas-

Oh. I already have the solution.

" Calm. "

Instantly, her terror vanishes, along with the panic and fight-or-flight reflexes. She merely sits on the floor and evaluates each person and robot, one by one for a few moments.

"I am sorry. I did not mean to make such a commotion. Please forgive my rudeness."

Her ridiculous transition from frightened rabbit to serene wolf makes me do a double-take, and I was the one who Wordsmithed at her. Sometimes this ability is ridiculous.

Samantha pulls away from me and walks over to the woman. "We didn't mean to startle you. I'm Samantha, this woman is Cassiel, and he is Hero."

"I see." The woman nods along as if seeing the four of us makes perfect sense now and little more needs to be explained. "My name is Rebecca. How may I assist you, and if I may be so bold, where am I?"

Cassiel walks over and helps Rebecca to her feet. "You're aboard a spaceship orbiting Earth. We located your facility under the surface and beamed you aboard because we need to speak with someone below."

Rebecca brushes off her coat, then seems to notice the thin strips of fabric that barely cover up Samantha's naughty bits. "I- I, um, see. You shouldn't have been able to locate us. We were hidden more than a hundred miles under the surface, and especially given we were shielded by three miles of dermacrete. What are you going to do now that you've found us?"

"Nothing. I'm not here to cause trouble or start a war. I just need to find whoever is in charge and speak with her."

"Her?" Rebecca echoes me, "You mean Marie Becker? She's the lead researcher for our facility. I'm sure she'd be willing to-"

Rebecca doesn't get to finish her sentence. At that moment, a faint *whump* is heard to my left, and I glance over to see another woman, this one in her forties with long red hair, pointing a gun at me. Having appeared out of nowhere, this catches the girls and me off-guard, and we quickly take a step back in surprise.

"Alright, *you*. That little stunt caught my attention, or did you think I wouldn't *notice*? Give me back my assistant, or I'll destroy your ship." She stares at me with a ferocious intensity, and despite the fact that the gun probably can't hurt me, it still makes me a little apprehensive.

"Miss Becker." Rebecca casually strolls over to her, and Marie stares at her suspiciously.

"Rebecca Blanc. You're acting differently from usual. Did they *do* something to you?"

I scratch my head sheepishly. "I don't mean to be rude, Marie. I think we've gotten off on the wrong foot. I just wanted to talk with the head of the facility, and I believe that's... you?"

She nods without stopping her visual examination of Rebecca. "Good job. You got my attention. I'm about a seven out of ten on the anger meter. Anything else?" She nods at something unknown before using her free hand to reach into her jacket and pulling out a tiny round device I've never seen before. I don't get to see it for more than two seconds before she presses it onto Rebecca's shirt, and the woman vanishes instantly, teleporting away somewhere.

I fumble for the right words to use. "Well, I don't know how else to say this, but I think we've met before. Maybe. It's a feeling in my head. Though, I sorta remember you looking... different."

Once her assistant is gone, Marie immediately slides the small gun into her waistband, as if completely unafraid of the human, demon, angel, and giant robot in the room. Actually, she's hardly looked at anyone yet, but now she turns her full attention to me. "Oh, I looked different. Brilliant observation. Was my hair longer? Perhaps I was wearing earrings? Are you just here to waste my time?"

Once she stops talking and stares at me for a moment, her demeanor toward me shifts. "Hold on. Wait... I do recognize you." She quickly looks at the other three in the room, and only now do I spot a look of terror on Cassiel's face. Marie notices it too. "What are you cowering about? I put the gun away. It was never the real threat anyway."

"I- um, I..." Cassiel's eyes widen, and a moment later she jumps from her chair and bolts out of the room. "I have to go!"

I start to chase after her, but Samantha quickly shoves me aside. "You stay. I'll see what's wrong."

With no input from me, both girls leave, and now it's just Marie and me, alone with the death robot.

"What was that all about?" Marie raises an eyebrow questioningly. "More importantly, what is a hero doing with an angel, the Second Emperor of Hell, and a..." She glances up at Ionis and blinks twice. Her expression doesn't change, but immediately I can sense something akin to panic overflow from her aura. "... *that*."

"It's a Sentinel." I speak the words slowly, wondering how such a confident woman can suddenly be rendered speechless at the sight of Ionis.

"Yes. I noticed." Her words are more curt and pronounced than before. "I suppose this monster is why you were confident you could abduct one of my faculty and not face your rapid destruction. Well played."

She's getting the wrong idea, and fast. "I'm not trying to do anything bad here, Marie. I just want to talk. I've been having dreams about the future lately, and uncanny hunches. They all

started a couple of weeks ago, and so far every one of them has been correct. You might just be the most important one because I have a feeling you can give me the answers I need."

To my surprise, she yawns and blinks back tears of boredom. "Oh. And here I thought it was important. Well, in any case, I've meant to talk with you specifically anyway, *Hero*. That is, with regards to the death machine you've created."

My eyes shift over to Ionis, then back to her. "I didn't make this."

"Not the Sentinel, stupid! The humans!"

I'm lost. "Err, the humans? What about them?"

She looks at me like I'm stupid. She might be right. "Didn't you arm humans with a ridiculous amount of highly advanced weaponry, then set them upon the Labyrinth?"

"Well, yeah. Why?"

She shakes her head slowly. "They have been slaughtering demons wholesale. Demons, monsters, anything in their way. In just a few short weeks, they've decimated the 415th and 842nd sectors. How little respect for life do you have, 'Hero'?" As if to accentuate her point, she nods at Ionis. "I guess they weren't doing enough, so you had to bring along one of those things too?"

I don't know what to tell her. "Killing demons is the point. They've been slaughtering humans for millions of years. They even trapped humans in bubble worlds and cut off their technology. I'm only leveling the playing field."

Marie rolls her eyes, "How gracious of you. How about you come down to my laboratory and take a look at some of the costs you've exacted upon the Labyrinth? The lizard-people are in ruins because of you. My precious babies were brutally tortured and maimed by ignorant savages with big guns, which *you* created."

Her words evoke frighteningly salient images in my mind. I can almost smell the burned flesh, and see barbs lanced into scaly green flesh. "I'm sorry. I should have realized it was my fault. I can't go to your laboratory though since Earth has that massive anti-energy field surrounding it. I hope you understand."

Her expression softens, just the slightest. "Ah, yes, that. When the Volgrim plunged the Moon into Earth, the method they used supercharged the moon into an anti-energy battery. The effect only grew in intensity once it mixed with the energy of the Moon and Earth's cores. I can see why you wouldn't want to go down there. Frankly, it's the safest place for humans in the galaxy. Demons can't go there, and Volgrim can't find us, even if they try."

She narrows her eyes. "Speaking of which, how *were* you able to locate our base? Wordsmithing shouldn't be able to penetrate the anti-energy field. In fact, with your pitiful level of energy, the effort would probably kill you."

"How do you know what Wordsmithing is?" Rather than answer her question, I take the offensive. "You shouldn't know anything about it."

A haughty laugh. "My dear Mister Hero, how little you know. I am quite possibly the smartest person in the galaxy. I've invented things you couldn't dream of. I can do things you wouldn't believe. I know almost everything there is to know."

I jerk my thumb at Ionis. "You didn't know about him."

Her smile evaporates. "Didn't anyone ever tell you nobody likes a smartass?"

"At least I'm smart." I stifle a huge grin. "I guess there are things even you don't know."

For once, her angry, haughty, petty emotions melt away. "I know plenty. More than I wish I did, sometimes."

The statement has an ominous ring to it. "You wanna elaborate on that?"

"No."

The two of us stare at each other silently for a few moments. Finally, she sighs. "Can you tell me what you're doing with the Second Emperor and an angel? Especially the angel. Lord knows there can't be many left alive."

"Cassiel is the last one. All the rest are dead."

"That's her name?" Marie looks at me in disbelief, and her jaw hangs open slightly. "She's one of the archangels, then? I thought there were only three or four at their peak."

"No. I just named her 'Cassiel' because she forgot her original name. I found her locked up, chained to a wall and left to die in the Labyrinth. It was one event of many that led me to... hate the demons."

Marie's surprise increases. "You hate demons? Then why are you traveling with that walking sex toy? The Second Emperor is basically the most powerful, influential demon in existence, barring the first. I suppose if she digs her claws in, you can't escape. Maybe you're not even in control here."

"Don't slur her like that. She's a real person with feelings. She isn't just a *sex toy*, Marie. I'm disgusted you'd even think like that about a fellow woman."

Marie covers her mouth with her hand in mock shame. "Oh, I'm so sorry. I didn't realize I was talking to a white knight. Whatever, it doesn't concern me." She reaches into her labcoat

and pulls out a small device, similar to the one she used on Rebecca. "This discussion has degenerated into the final vestiges of tedium that I would ever find remotely acceptable for conversation. If there isn't anything more important to say, I need to get back to work."

She's a tactless sociopath, but she's been at least somewhat helpful up to now. My eyes flick to Ionis, and back to her. "There's one thing I'd like help with. The Volgrim Founders, I need to locate them."

Marie barely blinks. "They're dead. Unless resurrection magic has been used without my knowledge, and I assure you I've only seen one resurrection in my lifetime, they are long gone."

A pause, she glances up at Ionis, and her eyes narrow in suspicion once more. "Why do you want to know about the Founders anyway?"

No getting around it. "The Sentinel needs to speak with them. He wishes to rebuild his kind."

Her expression doesn't change. I don't perceive any difference in her body language, but her eyes stay locked onto mine for several long, agonizing seconds. "He- he wants to... to rebuild... the other Sentinels? And... and you're going along with it?"

My gut churns, "Yeah."

"Oh my god. I already knew you were stupid, but this-"

I lurch back in surprise as Ionis suddenly screams into my mind. *ONE DAY, TWENTY-THREE HOURS, FORTY MINUTES, FIFTY-FIVE SECONDS. YOU WILL TAKE ME TO THE FOUNDERS.*

"What was that? Just now?" Marie looks at me in curiosity, and back to the robot. "Did something just happen?"

I wipe sweat from my forehead. "Ionis talks, sometimes, but only to me. It's sorta telepathic... but also not. He speaks normally, but only to me in a way I can hear."

Marie licks her lips. "If I speak to him, will he answer to you?"

"Can't hurt to try."

She nods, "Ionis, what do you intend to do when you locate the Founders? As I just said, they are all dead. There is nobody for you to find."

I WILL REBUILD THE SENTINELS.

I relay his message to her, rubbing my ears to try and massage the pain away. She continues, "But how? Even if the Founders were still alive, which they are not, there's no guarantee they could assist you. I know from my research that the Sentinels were created millions of years before even the Energy Wars on Earth, let alone the hundred million since. There is very little

chance any of the original scientists who created the Sentinels are still alive, so even they would be of no help. You will not be able to rebuild the others. And, if you can't do that, what will you do then?"

Ionis stares at her, his single iris lasering onto her face for five long seconds. *THERE ARE NO FOUNDERS?*

I relay the message, and Marie shakes her head. "That's what I've been saying. They're dead."

Ionis tilts his head slightly down, and for a moment it almost looks like the poor little instant-death Armageddon robot is sad. The moment passes.

I WILL CONFIRM THEIR DEATHS.

Marie throws her hands up in the air. "And then what? For an invincible war machine, you sure are thick as they come! You might even be dumber than this idiot!" She gestures at me, but I just ignore it.

Ionis doesn't respond. After ten seconds, Marie sighs. "You know, the Sentinels are, to me, a personal attack."

"I beg your pardon?"

She leans against Cassiel's chair, and a lingering wistfulness fills the air. "I said I'm the greatest scientist ever, but am I? I spent... I spent so long, trying to recreate a Sentinel. I failed, every time."

This blunt admission catches me off-guard. "You tried to make more of these things? Is there something wrong with you?!"

She waves her hand in my face. "Shut-shut-shuuut up. I don't even want to hear it from you. My point is that I feel annoyed, anxious, even angry that some washed-up emotionless alien morons were able to create death machines that I couldn't emulate. I can create anything! Why can't I build this one thing??"

Suddenly, as if she's made up her mind about something unbeknownst to me, Marie stands up alert. "I will help you."

"Huh? You mean with the Sentinel? Are you going to make more of them?!"

She shakes her head quickly. "No, certainly not. As I said, I couldn't even if I tried. Even with one right here I can experiment on, it would take ages to figure out. But what I can do is give you my files on all the Volgrim in existence. You can try and locate the original scientists from there." Marie glances at Ionis. "And maybe this trigger-happy fuckwit won't blow your brains out in the meantime. I'm surprised he's so calm right now as it is."

"Same." I wait silently as Marie pulls out a small datapad of some sort and starts tapping on the screen furiously, making menus come and go so quickly I can't catch even a single word. After a minute she smiles sweetly at me, a little *too* sweetly. "I hacked your ship's mainframe and uploaded all of my data on the Volgrim to it. You'll have to stay in orbit for a few minutes to let the data transfer, but once it's done, you should leave."

I nod, "I have to do so anyway. The Volgrim already know I'm here. Only quick thinking from Samantha and showing them the Sentinel made them leave us alone, but they'll be back, either to kill us, or to capture Ionis."

Marie reaches for her micro-teleporter gadget one last time. "I'm telling you, the Volgrim are dumber than you think. I wouldn't want to attempt a capture of a Sentinel, not after what I saw on Mars, all those eons ago. It's suicidal."

"Mars?"

She winks at me, "I've said enough. Get going. After you do whatever with this *thing*, I expect you'll get around to fixing the mess in the Labyrinth. The humans need to be restrained again, as per the Human Containment Act."

This doesn't sit well with me. "Isn't there another way? It's inhumane confining people to bubble worlds with limited technology."

Marie sneers immediately. "It's inhumane letting a child run around without a diaper before potty-training him too. You'll cover the house in feces. That's what the humans are doing now-destroying the delicate balance the Labyrinth was in. If you don't take steps to restore balance, and soon, *someone else* will. I don't think you'll like who that will be."

"Who?"

She shakes her head, "I hope you don't have to find out."

Considering that her goodbye, Marie tips her head at me, then activates her teleporter gadget. She vanishes an instant later, likely going back down to Earth.

Ionis swivels his eye at me. *YOU WILL TAKE ME TO THE FOUNDERS.*

"Shut up, you dense motherfucker."

Part 434c: Tortured Past

Marie's rapid exit leaves me standing alone on the bridge, with only the Sentinel and the air between us. The giant murder-machine stares at me silently, and finally I pull away from his singular gaze.

"Ionis, given you know more about the Volgrim than me, would you be willing to look through the data Marie gave us? You can probably figure out which Volgrim built the Sentinels faster than I can."

He immediately blares in my mind, *THAT ARRANGEMENT IS SATISFACTORY*.

"Great. Here, have a look." I can barely stand to look at his eerie single eye, so I glance away and hold the datapad toward him. I've scarcely lifted my hand before the pad vanishes from my grasp, almost teleporting into the robot's hand.

Fast!

I stare in amazement as he rapidly taps buttons on the screen at a speed that makes Marie's previous feats seem trivial. His fingers are a blur, but what's more shocking is that the pad can keep up with his inputs in the first place. Future technology is ridiculous.

A minute passes, but Ionis says nothing, and continues to do... whatever... on the pad. "Oookay, well, while you work on that, I need to be doing... literally anything else. Have fun."

The Sentinel says nothing, so I quietly leave the bridge.

He's a creepy one sometimes, but so far I've seen little of the bloodthirstiness everyone says he should have. As Cassiel said before, maybe he's a good robot? He did protect those humans, didn't he? That doesn't sound like something a genocidal murder-bot would do.

Crap, that's right! Cassiel! She fled when Marie appeared earlier, so I need to see what's going on with her.

My footsteps dully clank against the steel floor as I walk down the perfectly shined and sparkling aisles, turning left and right until I jump in surprise! Samantha walks around a corner again, nearly bumping into me.

"Oh!" She lets out a cute yelp, but only a flash of a smile crosses her face. It's quickly replaced with a look of trepidation. "Hero. You startled me. Um, are you going to talk with Cass?"

The look of worry on her face spreads to mine. "Yeah. Is she okay? She ran away, but, well, Marie kept me busy for several minutes."

Samantha leans against the wall to her left, her eyes downcast to my shoes. "Cass won't tell me anything, but she's a mess. She sobbed uncontrollably for several minutes, and I got the distinct impression she knows that woman very intimately. It was- it was like watching someone whose family had been murdered by a serial killer, only for them to meet that killer years later and be powerless to stop them from committing more murders."

"That sounds awful," I say, scratching my chin thoughtfully. "I'll have to be delicate when I talk to her."

"Yep." Samantha, to my surprise, pulls away from the wall, takes a step forward, and hugs me, a warm gesture unlike how she usually acts. "Thank you."

"It's my pleasure."

She pulls away and smiles softly before pushing past me and walking toward the Bridge. I cough into my fist.

"Uh, Sammy?"

"Yes?"

"The Sentinel is still on the Bridge, you know."

Her face whitens. "Oh. I'll uh, I'll be in the mess hall, in that case."

"That's a good idea."

She sheepishly turns at the corridor's end and hurriedly heads for the mess hall, and I continue walking to our room. The moment the door opens, I spot Cassiel lying on the bed, facing me, and she jerks back in surprise, quickly turning around and facing the wall. She wipes at her eyes as if she doesn't want me to see her crying.

"Cass? Are you okay?" I carefully inch into the room, not wanting to disturb her, and also because I feel a little anxious at how she's hiding her emotions from me. Come to think of it, ever since we've left Hero City, I haven't seen a negative attitude from her in all the time we've spent together. In fact, she's been more bubbly and happy than I thought possible.

"I'm fi-" Her voice catches, and she chokes it down. "-fine. It's nothing."

"That doesn't sound like nothing." I walk closer to the bed and sit at the far corner, close to her feet. The pillow is stained grey from tears, and as I notice that, she quickly pulls some covers over herself.

We sit silently for several long seconds, and I decide to break the silence. "Marie." The mere mention of the scientist's name makes Cassiel squeeze the covers tighter. Her fingers turn white from how hard she's holding the soft cloth. "Did you know her?"

"...no."

It's such a weak denial that I almost want to laugh. I don't though since she wouldn't say 'no' without a good reason. "You're a terrible liar."

She paws at her eyes again, though I can't see her face at all. "Sorry."

"You don't have to apologize, Cass." I lean forward and touch her hand lightly. Without looking, she twines her fingers with mine. "Won't you tell me what's going on?"

She shakes her head, then buries her face into the pillow. "I don't want to."

"Why not?"

A long pause. "Just... because."

"That's not an answer. Is it me? Did I make you mad? If it's something I did, I'm sorry."

"No!" Cassiel yells into her pillow, the fluffy down feathers muffling her voice somewhat, but still catching me by surprise. She quickly calms down. "It's just," She finally turns to look at me, her face stained with dried tears. "you worry so much about me. I don't want you to protect me from everything."

"O-okay. I understand." I try to force a smile, but seeing her cry is wreaking havoc on my guts. "If you don't want to tell me, I won't ask."

I start to pull away, but she squeezes my hand tighter. "Wait! That's- that's it? You're not going to keep asking?"

I'm suddenly confused. "No? If you don't want to say, then it's not my place to know. I'm your lover, not your father."

Finally, she turns around and sits up on the bed, facing me head-on. She dries her face with her robes, and snuffles, "Do you remember how we met?"

I blush slightly, "Well yeah, it was only a few weeks ago."

"I was chained to the wall and left to die." She says it so matter-of-factly, I can only nod.

"Uh huh."

"How do you think I got there?"

Her expression is serious now. She's already pushing whatever sadness from before to the back of her mind. I flip around and sit all the way on the bed, crossing my legs under myself like a monk. "To be honest, I never gave it much thought. I figured you would tell me if you wanted, and if not, then it wasn't my business."

She nods, "I don't like thinking about my past. I was chained to that wall for... for..." Her eyes cloud, and she seems to look through me for a few moments before returning to reality.

"...I lost track of time. Years, decades, eons. The only other being I saw was Gressil. He would come in to taunt me, stab me, anything to increase my suffering."

I make sure to keep a neutral expression. Never before has she been this open about her past. "That's impossibly hard to fathom. You're a stronger person than me."

"I wanted to kill myself." She gasps, as if the words are knives, impaling her as she speaks. "I was completely helpless. I could scarcely wiggle. I didn't even have the strength to bite my tongue. Even if I did, it wouldn't have killed me. Angels can heal very quickly."

I stay silent. It's better for me to listen, and let Cass get it out of her system. "When you found me and pulled me from that wall, I honestly thought I had died. There wasn't even the remotest possibility someone could appear to save me from my pain, even going so far as to laugh in the face of Gressil. It took me days to realize everything was real. The feeling of a warm sun on my back, cool air blowing through my hair, even when Adams kidnapped me, I was less scared of him and what he might do to me, and more that he would return me to that horrible place. It's a miracle I'm sane after all this time. It's a testament to the abilities of angels."

I nod dumbly, "I see. So why are you telling me this now?"

Cassiel's face suddenly contorts into a violent expression of rage that takes me aback. "Because. It's HER. That vile, putrid, scummy, worthless woman. Marie. I can never forget her face. How do you think I ended up where you found me? She put me there! Marie-" Cassiel's anger deflates in an instant, and she quickly looks away, an expression of horror on her face. "Marie tortured us, experimented, injected awful burning liquid into our veins, cut limbs off, and did so much more!! The cruel things she did, all for what she claimed was 'science,' it was inexcusable!"

Even as Cassiel's rage is replaced with fear and loathing, my own anger rushes in to fill the void. "She did all that to you?! Why didn't she remember you, then? She acted as if you were unimportant when I spoke with her. No, more importantly, what was her motive? What would-" I suddenly stop, realizing how I might be making Cass feel. "Sorry. I went overboard."

"It's fine, Hero." She brushes a strand of hair away from her face, pulling her hand from mine. "I used to ask those same questions every day. She mentioned the experiments were for a 'friend,' but she always laughed when we asked who. I think... I think she just enjoyed inflicting pain on us. She killed many of the remaining angels, you know. With her own hands, I mean."

"I don't know much about the angels. Is there a chance- do you think it's possible more may be alive? Maybe you weren't the only one to survive the experiments?"

The sadness lifts from Cassiel's face, but only slightly. "I doubt it. After Marie was done with us, she 'donated' us to the demons. Ten angels were devoured in front of my eyes. I was scared I

would be next, but it never happened. Instead, they locked each one of us away. Gressil would taunt me, telling me how many were left. Some died quickly, but others held on for a long time. Eventually, he told me I was the last one."

"Maybe he lied?"

She shakes her head, "Gressil is many things, and that includes a liar, but as time went on, he seemed to be growing sadder that so many of them were dying. I don't think he made their deaths up. He quite liked having *playthings* to torture."

Demons are evil. I want to say that, but my mind flicks to Samantha, and how decidedly not-evil she is. Then I remember what she told me recently about all the men she's killed.

Even if I assume the demons are vile monsters, what does that make me? Marie is a human, the same as I. Even now, humans are killing demons by the thousands in the Labyrinth, if Marie's words are to be believed. Those deaths are at least half my fault... so I can't say with any certainty that humans are superior to the demons.

I rustle around and lie down on the bed, stretching out so I can feel my joints pop. Cassiel follows along, laying on my arm as we both get more comfortable. Finally, I break the silence. "Do you want me to kill Marie?"

Cassiel snickers, despite the situation. "No, don't be silly. Two wrongs don't make a right."

I feel a little happier knowing the anguish she's feeling isn't there on the surface anymore, but at the same time, that thought makes me suspect I'm being selfish. "I could erase your memory of the past, Cass. Then you wouldn't have to think about that stuff ever again."

"That's sweet of you," She turns her head to peck me on the cheek. "but wholly unnecessary. The other angels died awful deaths. It wouldn't be fair for me to get out of that situation unscathed. Even if it hurts, it's part of who I am now. As my mother used to say, 'you either let fear and pain control you, or you outgrow it'."

"Your mother was very intelligent."

Cassiel closes her eyes, as memories of her mother enter her mind. "She was strong, right up to the very end."

Her words carry an ominous tone. "What do you mean by that? How did she die?"

She blinks her eyes open. "Marie killed her, of course. When myself and the other angels were captured, so were other humans. Marie needed to test the differences between human and angel biology. My mother was taken, just as I was."

"Jesus Christ." The words barely exhale from my lips. "That red-haired bitch. She'd better hope I never see her again..."

Cassiel quickly leans up, propping her chin on my chest and glaring at me. "See! This is why I didn't want to tell you. Don't do anything stupid! We have to learn to forgive those who wrong us. That's what I was always taught in church."

Forgive Marie? You're a goddamn saint, Cass. I sigh dramatically, but resign myself to whatever she wants. "Fine. I won't. If you change your mind though, just give me the word and I'll beat her to death with both of her arms. Fair?"

The mental image makes Cassiel laugh, in spite of the grim thought. "You're so overprotective! But fine, if I change my mind, you'll be the first to know."

"That's my girl." I toss her to the side and lunge at her playfully, planting a full kiss on her lips. "Hey, I have an idea."

She smiles at me bashfully, "Does it involve me?"

"Yeah. I say we make some good memories to replace the bad ones! Besides, I haven't been giving you the attention you deserve lately, have I?"

She chortles and puts on a mock expression of outrage. "No! It's so unfair! You always let Sammy sit in your lap and tease you! When am I gonna get some loving?"

I pull her a little closer, "There's no time like the present." Before she pulls me in for another kiss, I stick a finger between our lips. "By the way, were you serious when you said you wanted a duck?"

* * *

"It is worse than I thought. Those three have come into possession of a Sentinel."

Elder Kryios's holographic image shimmers in her usual seating spot, the small amount of travel lag caused by the vast distances making her words take several seconds to broadcast even after her lips have finished moving. Every Volgrim at the Council stiffens at once. Even I'm... surprised. It has been an eternity since I heard mention of those weapons of war. Even so, I feel a glimmer of greed, deep in my soul.

Elder Lozu, one of the members of the Anti-War faction, strokes his short brown beard thoughtfully. "A Sentinel, you say? That is indeed quite surprising. Have you any idea where they might have acquired such a relic?" He immediately looks at me, and the annoyance on his face is quite distinct. "I'm sure Elder Basil would love to know. For scientific purposes, of course."

Fool. We have a never-ending forever-escalating conflict on one front, and two species to keep in their place on the other, and Lozu thinks we can end battles with petty words. He

doesn't understand my motivations, or he pretends not to. Either way, the anti-war faction is a thorn in my side.

"Yes, I am quite anxious to learn where they procured such a specimen. Is it of new make or one of the originals? Did you obtain an identifier?" I attack her with questions, but of course, she deflects efficiently. It's her talent.

"Thanks to recording logs of our conversation, we have determined that the Second Emperor of Hell referred to the Sentinel as 'Ionis'. According to logs archived from the Third Age, we have corroborated with a very high likelihood that it is one of the originals. There is a chance that the images we were shown were fake, however..."

Elder Lozu interrupts, "What of the supposed sighting of a Sentinel, twelve-hundred-thousand cycles ago? Didn't a warship finally discover the original Volgarian homeworld, only for one of its scouting ships to be mysteriously destroyed? Are we to believe that was unrelated?"

Unfortunate. Elder Lozu is one of the younger members of the table. He wasn't on the council when that event happened, but I was. With the war against the Kolvaxians reaching a critical point, we couldn't afford to spare any resources to hunt down the Sentinel. We buried the information and hoped the machine wouldn't attack, and we lucked out.

Lozu, as always, stupidly believes in causes that have no basis in reality, and pushes opinions regarding things he knows little about.

"It was never confirmed, Elder Lozu, but yes, we suspected at the time it might be a Sentinel." Kryios answers for me, the several second delay in her audio allowing us time to mull over the implications of this new threat. "I suppose our suspicions have been confirmed, but now the question becomes... is it the only one?"

"That's NOT the most important question! The question we should be asking is why it has allied itself with a human, demon, and an angel!" Another elder across the room barks out in anger. "It should be returning to us, the ones who created it! Where is the loyalty?!"

Several members of the pro-war faction nod, but I quickly interrupt. "Not so fast. None of us were around for those dark days, but the Great Wars of Volgarian myth are quite real, I assure you. Based on logs taken from Founder Unarin's memories, my studies have indicated that the Sentinels were responsible for the mass evacuation of our original homeworld. I doubt a single one would be loyal to us, given that the final Great War was fought between Volgrim and machine."

Lozu smirks and leans back on his bench. "As expected, the leader of the barbarian faction would know all about the deadliest weapons that have ever existed. Now, will you offer a sane

strategy for dealing with this weapon, or are we doomed if it turns its firepower toward us?"

Before I can respond, Elder Kryios interrupts. "Elder Lozu, the disrespect toward your senior councilman is unwarranted. Keep your tongue in check."

I smirk at him as he turns away to stew. It still amuses me that the demons think we're an emotionless hivemind, for it is times like this that show me we are just as fractured and broken as the other species.

Well, not that we'd ever let them know that. We still have our pride, even if we fight among each other.

Elder Kryios continues, "Even if we had a method to defeat them, which we do *not*, we certainly lack the military personnel to do so. A single Sentinel might as well be a million. It will think faster than us, move faster, attack faster... we would need to encircle it with a trillion starfighters and hammer it with all of our might, and possibly find a way to disable its systems. I verily doubt our capability of doing so."

That seems to shut Elder Lozu up. He squirms in his seat uncomfortably. "So it's hopeless, then."

I squeeze my hands together, pretending in the back of my mind that his neck is in my grasp. "The Sentinels have only been defeated once. The Founders were the ones to finally stop them, but all are long-since dead. We may never know what method they used, and therefore must hope with all our power that this... 'Ionis'... does not turn his gaze toward us."

Kryios lowers her head, a sense of defeat in the air around her hologram. "If only we had not let the Founders take their secrets to the next life... we might have had a chance."

A solemnness pervades the air before another Elder coughs into his fist. "It seems there is nothing we can do regarding the Sentinel at this time. If that is the case, I move that we continue to the next topic regarding Sector 1642 and the expansion of the Kolvaxian plague. All in favor?"

"Aye," everyone chimes in simultaneously. "Aye," I repeat quietly, as my mind turns to thoughts of what that machine could do for the war effort.

* * *

His bare feet slap against the black tiled floor, as he walks through the dark corridors. Every step echoes differently, like wraiths cackling inside the walls, tormenting him and laughing at the trial he must now undergo. Diablo breathes heavily as he passes sleeping quarters, sacrificial chambers, and finally through a great Feasting Chamber. He enters the room with little fanfare, but many of the regulars spot him in an instant.

"Oy! It's the Third!" A shadow-walker glances up from his mug and stares in awe as the most visible of the ruling Emperors strolls through the hallway. "It's me, Tvoorik! Do you recognize me?!"

Diablo barely even looks at the young demon. "No. Don't bother me right now."

His palms glisten with wetness, and he brushes them smoothly on the black robes he wears. It isn't often he's forced to wear such formal attire, but this meeting is one he has put off for several days, and waiting longer will only increase the pain.

The shadow-walker looks miffed. "Fine, sheesh."

"Tvoorik!" Another shadow-walker nudges him angrily. "Show some respect!"

"Sorry."

Diablo is halfway through the room when a familiar black skinned Animus falls into stride beside him. "Third Emperor, Diablo. It has been a while since we last spoke."

The two of them exit through the opposite door and continue walking towards wherever Diablo is headed. The Third Emperor blinks twice, realizing the other was speaking to him. "Huh? What do you want, Smealum?"

Smealum rubs his hands together, "Nothing in particular. I'm just curious about what you're up to. Especially wearing that formal attire." He snickers to himself. "You're pale too, like you're about to see Death himself." Suddenly his smile evaporates. "Or... the next worst thing... I suppose."

Diablo gnashes his teeth together and stops, turning to Smealum with a fiery glare. "I'm going to see the First Emperor."

Smealum takes a step back, holding his hands up to his chest. "T-the First? Why would you ever need- I mean, I thought he hated to be bothered?"

"He. Does." Diablo bites the words off, nearly exhaling fire from his nose. "Again, I ask you... do you need something, or can it wait?"

"Wait. It can. I can wait- waiting is what I can do!" Smealum stutters weakly before bowing and scurrying away.

"Great. Do that." Diablo speaks the words to nobody in particular before carrying on. It takes many more minutes of walking before he eventually locates a hidden lever on a wall, down a Labyrinth passage none would ever use- *especially* if they knew where it led. Pressing his hand against the wall, he mutters in the old Demonic language, 'Elde no'la vernum', and a wall slides open just enough for him to fit his bulk through. Once he passes through, it seals behind him.

Diablo continues walking, occasionally smacking his hands together in a feeble attempt to stop them from shaking, but it does little. Eventually, he enters a grand hallway, expanding outward in every direction with colossal torches, nearly fifty feet high. The flames burning atop each are that of bonfires, signaling the appearance of a demon unlike any before him. Diablo continues walking, but his pace slows as that familiar aura of pure blackness seeps from every corner of the room, intensifying each step he takes.

Soon, it is not a trickle of power, but that of a howling wind, as he arrives at a golden throne, with diamonds, sapphires, and many other exotic gems embedded in every nook and cranny of the thing. Towering a hundred feet tall, the throne is dwarfed only by its occupant, a demon of unthinkable height. Wearing a rich blue and purple robe, the First Emperor hides his face with a black veil, though his blood-red eyes shine through it like a crimson sun over a muddied horizon.

Diablo falls to his knees and prostrates himself, shivering as he feels the gaze of the First beating down on him.

" Why have you disturbed me, Third Emperor? You know how I loathe trifles. "

His voice is like a hurricane, battering the smaller demon savagely, though Diablo steels himself and carefully grips the red and gold rug that stretches from the throne hundreds of feet to the doorway whence he came.

"I beg your forgiveness. I have only come to speak with you at the urging of the Volgrim, First Emperor... Asmodeus."

Part 435c: Enigma

A far more cheerful Cassiel and I enter the lunch hall, and we spot Samantha doing her exercises. This time, she's standing on a single toe and bending over backward in the most gravity-defying stunt I've ever seen, with her other leg stretched out in front of herself to balance the rest of her body, though only her long black hair touches the ground.

She turns and smiles when Cassiel waves. "Hey! You're back!" Flipping around, she lands like a cat on the floor, then hops up to her feet. She's far more nimble than any gymnast I remember from my time on Earth. Her smile falters as she glances down toward our feet. "What's that thing?"

Cassiel reaches down and picks up what caught her attention. "Hero made me a ducky! His name is Howard!"

The white-feathered duck stares forward silently, unamused by everyone around him. When Cassiel gives him a poke, he lets out an odd, croaky noise. "Wark."

Samantha scratches her head. "It's been a long time since I saw creatures from Earth, but that duck doesn't sound right."

"Wark." The duck rumbles throatily again, and Cassiel grins in response. "He's so unique! Isn't Howard adorable?!"

Samantha glances at me for a split second before quickly smiling at Cassiel. "Yes! He's cute! I'm glad you like him!"

The two of them pet the duck for a minute, then start whispering conspiratorially, while glancing at me every few seconds. I finally have enough and clear my throat. "Ahem, if you two are done having fun, we need to head to the bridge. We've been in orbit around Earth long enough, and we need to get going before the Volgrim decide to attack us."

Their playful expressions fade quickly. I feel a little guilty, but both girls hop into step beside me, and we walk back through the hallway, while Samantha whispers up into my ear, "I'm proud of you. You made her day... even if you *did* take your sweet time in the bedroom."

Cassiel doesn't hear, as she's busy feeding the duck bread I created for her. I loop my arms around both of my beautiful girls, and a minute later we step onto the bridge. Ionis is standing silently, his finger the only thing moving as ridiculously fast as before. For once, I notice that Samantha doesn't tense up when she sees him. Is she getting used to his presence? Hard to say.

The three of us take our seats, and I watch the automaton for a few moments, but he doesn't say anything. *Guess I have to break the silence.* "Ionis, how is your progress? Have you found any Volgrim of interest?"

The response is swift. *EXACTLY FOUR THOUSAND, SIX HUNDRED AND SEVENTY-FIVE VOLGRIM ARE RESPONSIBLE FOR THE CREATION OF THE SENTINELS. I HAVE LOCATED ONLY FIFTEEN ON THIS LIST.*

Oof. Well, at least that narrows down the list of possibilities. "You're not going to be pissy and kill everyone if these fifteen aren't alive, right? I can't perform miracles, you know."

YOU WILL TAKE ME TO THE FOUNDERS.

Yeah, yeah. This robot is more like a broken record than a death-machine at this point. Ionis suddenly appears at my side, hand outstretched, holding the datapad in front of my face. He moved so quickly I didn't even perceive it! A shudder goes down my body as I take it from him. He lowers his hand but continues to stand uncomfortably close to me as I glance at the names and faces onscreen. Finally, I clear my throat, "Uh, could you like, give me some space, Ionis?"

He doesn't move. *I AM UNABLE TO PROCESS THE CREATION OF ADDITIONAL VOID WHERE YOU STAND.*

"Christ, it's a figure of speech. Can you go stand over there?"

The words barely leave my mouth, and he seemingly teleports where I'm pointing. I breathe a sigh of relief as I look over the list he gave me.

Unarin, Dosea, Trayza, Cuanali, Cinculu, these are the five founders, but additionally, there are ten other Volgrim on the list. *Elder Virrus, Elder Sirn, Elder Milphor, High-Priest Edduras, and more besides them.* Their names and faces are here, along with short biographies, though the bios are a bunch of tiresome titles, places they've served at, and feats they're accomplished, nothing I care about.

Samantha leans over in her seat beside me and gazes at their faces. "I recognize a few, mostly the founders, but I'd be hard-pressed to remember any of their names. Since five are already dead, that really only leaves ten we can look up, right?"

"Yeah," I quickly look up at Ionis, who now has his single eye fixed on me, "I hope at least one of the aliens on this list is alive."

"I don't," murmurs Samantha under her breath.

Samantha and I look into each other's eyes for a moment, and I understand exactly what she means. If someone on this list can rebuild the Sentinels, then we'll be directly responsible for creating more of these monstrosities. It would be a boon if more couldn't be built.

Again, a thought enters my mind. *I could teleport myself and the girls out of here, and that Sentinel couldn't possibly find us. I need to think of the galaxy though, and I can't afford to wake up this death machine, only to unleash it on the populace, even if they are Volgrim. This is bigger than the three of us.*

Cassiel leans over and flops her head against my left arm, sighing. "So what now? Are you going to ask that nice Volgrim lady from earlier if we can talk with people on the list? I don't think she'll be too keen on the idea."

"I considered it."

Both girls look at me immediately like I'm stupid, but I cough and clarify. "Obviously it wouldn't work though, so Wordsmithing is the next best option. I'm going to try and use Locate to find any living survivors. That's the best I can do."

Cass pounds her fist into her palm. "Oh! That's smart! Then you'll not only know if they're alive, but you'll also know instantly, and exactly where they are!"

Samantha's face contorts into mock annoyance. "Yes, but if they're somewhere in the heart of Volgrim space, good luck getting to them. I fear even Wordsmithing won't make that mission easy."

I stare intently at the datapad, and my nerves start to jitter slightly. "Let's not be Downer Debbies just yet. This will only take a minute." Saying that, I focus my mind on the picture of the first female, Elder Virrus. " **Locate!** "

A moment passes. My mind hunts the vast cosmos and finds nothing. One down, nine to go. " **Locate!** "

The girls watch silently, as does Ionis. One by one, I look at a portrait and the name, focus my mind, and say 'locate.' Each time, I fail. After I finish, I glance at the girls. "It's a bust."

Cassiel's shoulders deflate immediately, but Samantha seems unsure of whether she should be happy or worried. After all, we either give the Sentinel what he wants and create a bunch of death machines, or we don't, and he might kill us. It's a lose-lose either way. "You only did ten of them. Try the Founders next."

"Huh? Why? They've been confirmed dead already."

Even as she aims her face at me, Samantha's eyes nudge towards Ionis. "Don't you want to, you know, try every possible solution? Just give it a shot."

I see your point, wise succubus, my mind whispers. I aim my mind at Unarin, " **Locate.** "

Nothing happens.

I aim my mind at Dosena, " **Locate.** "

Nothing happ- wait. No, there's something...

" **LOCATE!** "

I try again, and this time I feel the vast cosmos open up. An invisible spirit seems to guide me along to an unseen place, outside of the normal space we know. I blink in surprise as I see her, the Volgrim female, sitting at a table among others of her kind. Seconds later, I pull back, a feeling of surprise and confusion surrounding me. "I don't believe it. The second Founder, Dosena, is still alive."

"Whoa! That's amazing!" Cassiel lights up like the fourth of July, but Samantha's emotions are much more muted.

"Hm. I wondered." She crosses her arms and bites her lip, "So where is she? A secluded facility, perhaps under lock and key? I always thought it was too convenient that all five of the Founders would die so easily."

I shake my head, "No. She's not even in what we call 'normal space,' she's in a completely different dimension. Much like how the Labyrinth exists outside of our galaxy, so does hers. However, that also means going to see her will be very simple. I can open a wormhole directly there."

Ionis's eye swivels to face me. *YOU WILL TAKE ME TO THE SECOND FOUNDER.*

"Yeah, duh. That's the game plan."

Jesus, this robot is a walking ball of stupidity. I don't know how these single-minded machines ever once terrorized the galaxy when they're so braindead. I feel like I could just keep leading him on forever and he would never catch on.

Cassiel taps her foot impatiently. "Well? Are you going to take us there or what?"

"No, not just yet. Let's get out of this sector first. The last thing I want is for us to leave and then return to a ship surrounded by an armada of angry Volgrim with giant guns pointed at us."

"Aw." Cassiel shrugs and her expression deflates, but she gets up and flutters to the navigation console, stares at it blankly, then turns to me. "So, where do we go?"

For once, I have no idea. "I don't know anything about the galaxy. What's the closest star? Actually, we should probably aim for a spot in space far from any star systems. Find somewhere several thousand lightyears away. I'll use my wordsmithing to create... uh... what was it called again? The energy source?"

"Trifrancium." Cass clicks her tongue thoughtfully. "Let me know if you need any energy. I can help you make a bunch. Twenty grams should be enough to let us escape the Terran system in a half minute, but a kilogram will..." She pauses to tap buttons on the panel, "...a kilogram will get us to the edge of the galaxy in a few hours, perhaps half a day."

"Whoa." Samantha leans back in her seat, surprise written all over her face, "Isn't the galaxy ridiculously huge? How could we possibly move that fast?"

Cass shakes her head. "Well, *we* can't. At least, in the past I was raised in, humans would perish in minutes at a sustained speed of beyond Warp 8.42, but if we were to go visit this Volgrim lady, Jason could set a wordsmithing beacon aboard the ship, and it could travel while we were gone. Then we just return to it once we're done, and boom!"

"That's smart. Good idea, Cass. We'll do that, then." I get up and walk over to her to pat her head, as well as the duck's. "I suppose if that's going to be the game plan, go ahead and start jumping now and I'll fabricate the Trifrancium in bursts. We still have, what, ten grams in the cargo hold? That should be enough to give us a rapid boost out of here. The Volgrim won't know how we did it!"

Samantha slinks up behind me and points at Earth, still in the ship's viewscreen. "Just a random thought, don't you find it odd the Volgrim didn't want us coming here, and then we found that woman? Do you suppose they know about her?"

Cass answers for me, "Doubt it. The Volgrim I know would never fraternize with a human."

"Then by bringing her aboard the ship, have we potentially doomed her? What if the Volgrim find out about her existence and decide to finish her off after we leave?"

I don't get a chance to answer. Cass jerks back and glares at Samantha. "Good riddance." She quickly realizes what she did, and her expression softens. "Oh, s-sorry Sammy. I didn't- I didn't mean to snap at you."

"I don't blame you, love." Samantha, bless her heart, leans over and kisses Cassiel on the cheek. "We'll just look past it. I'll send you to anger management classes, or something."

The two of them share their touching moment, so I slip away and head for the exit. Before I can leave, I perceive motion to my side, and Ionis falls into step.

THE SECOND FOUNDER WILL RESIST ANY ATTEMPTS TO BRING THE SENTINELS BACK ONLINE.

I continue walking toward the engine room as Ionis follows. "Can you blame her? Sounds like your kind has a real reputation for murder and mayhem."

MY PROGRAMMING INDICATES THAT ELIMINATING BIOLOGICAL LIFE IS MY PRIMARY FUNCTION.

"Well, you're doing a pretty shitty job. You've got four biologicals on this ship right now, including the duck. Why haven't you blown us to bits, or the other humans from Volgarius, for that matter? Don't you give a damn about your programming?"

We arrive at the engine bay, and I tap a screen to display our Trifrancium reserves inside the radiation containment unit. The stuff can kill if exposed to it directly for more than a few seconds, Wordsmith or not.

I AM ONLY INTERESTED IN ELIMINATING THREATS TO MY EXISTENCE. MY CURRENT PRIMARY OBJECTIVE IS TO REBUILD THE OTHER SENTINELS. WITHOUT POINTS, KILLING BIOLOGICALS LACKS ANY PURPOSE.

Points? What's he going on about now? I aim my mind at the radiation tank. "**TRIFRANCIUM!**" Several grams of the stuff appears, and I feel my energy drain somewhat. "So are you saying you didn't kill the humans on Volgarius because they weren't a threat?"

AFFIRMATIVE.

"And what about when those Volgrim attacked the human base millions of years before? Are you saying you weren't protecting the humans?"

AFFIRMATIVE. THE LIKELIHOOD THAT THE VOLGRIM SCOUTING CREW MIGHT COME INTO CONTACT WITH THE CREATION WELLS AND DESTROY THEM WAS 2.9%, A SUFFICIENTLY HIGH ENOUGH CHANCE THAT THEIR ELIMINATION WAS NECESSARY.

"Huh. And here I thought you had a soft spot for humans. **TRIFRANCIUM!**" I take a deep breath as several more grams of the radioactive material appears, and my energy drains substantially more. "What's that stuff about 'Creation Wells'? Something to do with Sentinels?"

This time, Ionis doesn't respond.

Huh. Guess I hit that nail on the head.

"You're an enigma, Ionis. A real mystery."

* * *

"Can you believe the progress we've made in the last month?" Marco, a thin, gangly looking young man, with flat black hair and soft brown eyes, wheezes as he finishes his cigarette off and tosses it to the ground, stomping it out with his military boots. "The demons are running scared. Just one human rounds a corner, and they bolt away! Funniest shit I ever saw."

"Yeh. Das right." Sergei, a towering mountain of muscle, too big to wear ordinary combat fatigues, rubs up against the wall behind him to scratch his back, while delicately holding the fading torch in his huge hands. The back of his sleeveless T-shirt rips, but he doesn't notice. "Them flee when they see us. Hehe."

Marco narrows his eyes to peer down the dark hallway, but the contingent up ahead is still lounging around, their forms barely illuminated by the torches mounted on the walls around them. "Can't wait until I get to go back to Hero City. The Labyrinth is the dumps. The only fun I get is blowing a demon to kingdom come. Know what I mean?"

"Yeh. They head go pop, hehe." Sergei mindlessly tugs at his bushy black beard and rubs his stomach. "Hungry."

"I feel you. We'll be off this ridiculous shift in a couple hours. If we're lucky, we'll get some action soon, and you can roast a demon alive! Then you get something to eat, even if it does taste like *demon*." Marco licks his lips thoughtfully. "You know, rumor has it that there are succubus girls among the demons. They have really nice, perky tits, and they love to eat cock. I'd like to get a taste of those, know what I mean?"

Sergei nods eagerly. "Heh, yeah, yum yum cock, heh."

"No stupid! The girls, not the goddamn- whatever." Marco sighs, his mental image ruined. "I didn't know you rolled that way. You oughta- oh! Look alive, someone's coming."

Sergei pulls away from the wall, and both him and Marco salute as a half dozen troopers walk from the opposite end of the hallway, their torches much fresher and brighter than the guards'. One man in particular, with long jagged eyebrows and a thick, full nose, looks right at them and salutes back. "Anything to report?"

Marco's eyes light up as he evaluates the man in an instant. "Commander Saul?! You're from the Gold Contingent! I have nothing of interest to report, sir. Wish I did though."

Saul sighs heavily, and as Marco gazes, he spots many bags under the commander's eyes. "It's all fun and games, killing demons, right? Anyway, I've heard rumors from scouts that a platoon of demons has mobilized and is heading to this section of the 16th block. Make sure your powersuits are ready. Double-check your weapons, be certain the fuel cells and batteries are fresh. I don't need good men dying on me just because they were running at fifty percent, understood?"

Marco nods eagerly. "Absolutely! I always keep my equipment maintained, sir! Can I just say, I'm a huge fan? I followed what you did during the Clone Crisis in Hero City. You saved a lot of lives."

Saul doesn't return the youngster's beaming smile. "The memories are still fresh. Just remember, there are no good guys in a war. Understand?"

Marco raises an eyebrow in confusion but awkwardly smiles even harder. "Right! It's good to be bad, sir!"

"I didn't mean- ah, whatever." Saul rubs his Buddha Palm against his left hand, sighing. He pushes past the eager face of the young man and mutters to himself quietly, "I just wish the bells would stop tolling."

"What?" Marco stares at the commander blankly, but Saul ignores him and continues walking to the contingent stationed further up the hallway. Eventually, Marco and Sergei are all alone, once more.

The giant man relaxes once the commander is gone and leans back against the wall. "Me think he want friend with demon."

"Yeah right." Marco rolls his eyes. "Who'd want something like that? Demons are murdering monsters. Ugly, too. That nasty red skin, and the horns- yuck! Just looking at them gives me the heebie-jeebies."

"Me think skin look like apples." Sergei rubs his stomach again. "Apples sound real tasty right now."

"Would you knock it off with all the food talk? Jeez, now I'm starting to feel hungry." Marco lifts his flamethrower unit and shifts its weight a little bit, before sighing. "I wanna go home and find a nice piece of ass. A guy can't even get a private moment in this place."

Suddenly, a commotion at the end of the hallway, from where the Commander arrived, makes Marco stiffen. He quickly stands at attention and raises his flamethrower, just in case. Seconds later, a lone man races around the corner, his arms flailing and his torch smacking against the wall as he almost loses his footing. The young lad runs up to them, breathless. "*Guh - wheeze* - sound the alarm! Demons! They're attacking the *suh* -second and third company in block twenty-four!"

Marco's alarm dies down a little bit. "Oh, aren't those two of our strongest groups? Are you telling me they can't handle some demons? Just hit them with the Juggernauts and you'll clean house."

Before Marco can react, the young man reaches up and slaps him across the face, nearly knocking him off his feet. "It's a goddamn order from the General, you fucking clod! Get your asses in gear and get down there! They're wiping the floor with us!"

Saul appears at Marco's side, having heard the young man screaming. "What's going on?" After he's filled in, he nods. "Right. I'll send this company to meet up with them. I'll contact Gold Contingent and see what else I can scrape together. How many demons are down there?"

The younger soldier pauses for all of three seconds, "About five thousand, sir!"

Saul glances at Marco, then back to the new face. "The Second and Third Company number almost twenty thousand strong. How could you possibly be having trouble holding back so few demons?"

"They're ferocious! I've never seen anything like it! Even anti-energy is having almost no effect on them."

Saul's expression darkens. "I'll contact the King. Get moving."

He runs down the dark hallways, alone, letting out only a small flame from his Buddha Palm as he makes his way toward the communications station nearby.

Thoughts rage in his mind, like a maelstrom of confusion.

Demons can't beat technology. That's what we were told, that's what we've seen. So, if that's the case, what changed?

Part 436c: Voldarius

A peaceful meadow. Flowers are blooming, the small sun in the sky beams down rays of warmth, the wind isn't blowing, but it could be if this planet had anything resembling a pressure system, and all is well on the *very* small planet of Voldarius.

The four of us step out of the portal and look around in wonder. The horizon of this tiny planet is much nearer than I'm used to since the planet itself has a diameter of just under ninety-five miles. Indeed, I take notice of how the ground begins to curve away at a mile or so in the distance, and as I predicted, this is one of only a few spots on the planet without any civilization to be found. Better to walk peacefully into the nearest village than to appear suddenly in a population center and panic everyone.

As the portal closes behind us, Cassiel flutters her wings and sets Howard down. "Oooh! Sunlight! Grass! This place is nice. It reminds me of Earth, a little bit."

A small bug, resembling a grasshopper, leaps from the grass and flutters past, landing a few dozen feet away before taking off again, quickly fleeing our immediate vicinity. Samantha stretches mightily, "The gravity feels a lot weaker here. Anyone else notice that?"

I tap my toes down and notice I lift off the ground slightly. "You're not kidding. If I put my strength into it, I could probably jump into escape velocity. That's a good path to dying in the vacuum of space."

Ionis says nothing and immediately begins marching toward the direction of the nearest city. As he walks past me, I glare at him. "Hey! Where do you think you're going? I only agreed to bring you with us because leaving you behind made me antsy. If these Volgrim see a goddamned Sentinel marching into their capital, what do you think is going to happen?"

Ionis continues walking, but his eye swivels around his head to look at me. *THEIR PRIMITIVE WEAPONRY WILL BE NO THREAT. I MUST FIND THE FOUNDER.*

The girls sigh and keep pace with me as I jog to catch up with him. "That's beside the point. I already scryed this world, so I know what their military capabilities are. Even if they're no threat, if everyone panics and flees, the Founder might be killed in the stampede. Is that what you want?"

Ionis slows his pace, but only a little, as if he's hesitant. *YOU WILL TAKE ME TO THE FOUNDER.*

Groan.

Cassiel nudges me after a few minutes of walking. "I could fly and have a look to see how far away we are."

"You just want an excuse to use your wings. Well, not that I can blame you... they are rather majestic." I give her a lighthearted poke and she giggles.

"Yep! What good are wings if you don't use them? They're about the only perk being an angel has given me!" She takes off, flying up into the air, but her smile feels fake in my mind. *Somehow, that sentence was one of the saddest things I've ever heard her say*, I think to myself.

I guess immortality isn't a perk if everyone she's ever known has died, in some cases right in front of her, while she's also lost the ability to taste and enjoy food. Kinda reminds me of Amelia, actually.

Hmm, Amelia. I haven't thought about her in years. I wonder why she comes to mind at a time like this?

"I'm glad Cass is having fun," says Samantha, as she watches Cassiel do three loop-the-loops above us. "I hope the two of you worked out some issues. I've never seen her cry like that before."

"Yeah." I feel a sudden stinging pain in my chest, "She was broken when I first met her. She told me she wanted nothing more than to die. I guess finally being free and having people that care about her has allowed her to bloom like a flower in spring, but the damage is still there. It will never be gone."

Across the horizon, the outlines of distant buildings become visible. Samantha slides her arm around mine and leans against me, but this time she isn't seductive or alluring. A troubled cloud passes across her face. "You asked me once about how I could love you when you have killed so many demons, while you love me, the second most powerful of all demons. I have to ask, then... how do you think Cass feels toward me?"

"Huh?" I try my best not to look too concerned by her question. "You think just because demons tortured her; she would blame you? Cassiel isn't that kind of person. She's better than that."

"Come on, Hero. Think about it. I have the power to lead the demons and order them to do my bidding, but I never use it. I selfishly pursue my own needs and desires, and because of my inaction, I let a sweet girl like Cassiel be tortured by Gressil, a demon who serves directly under me. She could have been freed eons earlier along with the other angels. I never had anything against their people, and with Satan gone, I could have rallied the demons together to put the hatred between our species firmly in the past. But... I didn't."

Now I see her eyes downcast, guilt pouring from every point of her body. "It's my fault Cassiel wasn't released. If... if I hadn't been so selfish..."

I reach down and touch Samantha's hand lightly. "You can't think like that. Everyone makes mistakes. Cassiel was terrified when she first met Beelzebub, but she never seemed afraid of you, and aside from not having red skin, that tail of yours is a dead giveaway for being a demon. She must have sensed you were different from the others."

"Am I?" Samantha looks up into my eyes, a sense of pleading evident in her expression. "I've killed. You've killed. The only one who hasn't is Cassiel. Her hands are clean. She's better than both of us, and she forgives easily."

I boop Samantha lightly on the nose. "She killed Gressil, even if it was self-defense. She isn't perfect, so don't put her on a pedestal like that. She wouldn't want that."

Samantha stops suddenly, jerking me to a halt as well. "What? She killed Gressil? When? I heard nothing about this."

Thoughtfully, I scratch my chin and pull away from her. "You don't remember? It was explosive. She hit him with a blast of energy, disintegrating his body. I'm sure you were there."

The succubus slowly shakes her head. "No, Jason, I wasn't. In fact, I'm positive Gressil is still alive. Maybe you've just mixed something else up."

A strange, eerie feeling washes over me. "Uh. Maybe. Yeah, sorry. I must have forgotten." I quickly realize Ionis is still walking, so I nod toward his back. "Let's not, uh, fall behind."

She carefully loops her arm through mine again, and we power-walk to catch up, but that strange feeling in my gut won't go away. "You're sure she didn't kill him? The memory is so... vivid."

Samantha purses her lips. "No, love. I'll ask her about it later, but I think you're just being forgetful."

Cassiel interrupts us, falling from the sky and stopping with a single, graceful flap of her wings, just to land daintily on her feet. She quickly stands up straight and salutes, catching me off-guard. "Scout Leader Cassiel reporting in, sir! I have surveyed the area, and have a report!"

Samantha snickers in spite of our discussion a moment before. She quickly hides the expression and puts on a military stare. "Scout Leader, what do you have to report? Command is asking for confirmation of the, the err... the..."

I nudge her, "Bogeys."

"Right! The bogeys!"

Cass's face twitches, and I can tell she's trying not to burst out laughing, but she valiantly keeps her serious expression taut. "I have found a small village up ahead! Several of the Volgrim there spotted me flying around, so no doubt they will be expecting us at any minute!"

Her cute words make the humor in the situation vanish for me. "They saw you? I don't know if that's a good thing, Cass."

Cassiel's smile fades. "Aw, come on. Seeing a cutie like me flying around probably melted their hearts! They're going to be so excited to meet me! And you guys too, I guess. Maybe not the Terminator, over there."

At the mention of Ionis, the three of us suddenly realize we've been dawdling for a whole minute already. The robot is way ahead now, so I save time and wordsmith to catch up to him. "**Teleport!**"

This time, we stay in step with him, as many buildings begin to appear in the distance. Several minutes pass, as we chat about this and that, but once we draw closer the people on the horizon become distinguishable from one another. A hundred or so watch silently, and they are quite the diverse group of spectators. Kids, adults, grandparents, men, women, even one in something resembling a wheelchair. We stop once we're a hundred feet away from the crowd, and I quickly scan their faces.

Samantha looks up at me. "Can you speak Volgarian?"

"No. I can Wordsmith though, probably can make myself speak it."

She nods. "I'm fluent though, so I'll introduce us. A single slip of the tongue could cost us dearly."

"Sounds good," I look to my right at Ionis. "As for you, don't make any threatening moves. We're stuck on this planet for seventeen hours until the ship arrives at the edge of the galaxy, so I'd rather not piss these people off. Got it?"

YOU WILL TAKE ME TO THE FOUNDER.

"That's not a 'yes,' fuckstick. Did I make myself clear?"

Ionis's eye swivels to face me. When he speaks, there's almost a hint of annoyance in his voice.

YES.

"Fantastic. Glad to hear it."

A male Volgrim, looking like a 40-year-old human, steps away from the crowd and cautiously walks toward us. I wordsmith under my breath, "**Language,**" just so Cassiel and I

can understand him.

"Hello, travelers. I am Norek, of the Supply and Labor Branch." His clean-shaven face contrasts with his dirty clothes and gloves covered in grass and plant matter. He stares first at Cassiel in wonder, then for several moments at Ionis, before barely looking at me and turning his attention to Samantha, who has stepped forward as the representative for our group. "I noticed the winged one in the sky, and was afraid for several minutes, but it would seem that you have not brought any weapons. Where do you come from, and what is your business with our spheroid?"

As he speaks, I notice the crowd behind him whispering to one another, and cautiously pointing at either Samantha or me, though it's hard to tell since she's in front of the group. I get the impression they're mostly looking at me.

Samantha bows slightly and then raises her pointer finger in the air. "I am Belial, Second Emperor of the demons. This is Cassiel, Highest of the Angels, and this is Hero, the leader of humanity, along with..." She glances at the robot, unsure of what to say. "...Stinky, our pet robot. We've come to speak with your leader, Dosena. Would it be possible to secure an audience with her?"

I'm not used to Samantha being so formal, but it seems the title of Second Emperor isn't just for show. When she needs to, she can be a leader at the drop of a hat. I'm a little impressed, to be honest.

Norek nods sagely, "Belial, Cassiel, Hero, and Stinky, it is my honor to welcome all of you. I do apologize, as we were not expecting visitors... given we have never had any, even as far back as the earliest records of our civilization will go. I must also prostrate myself again, as I am young and not familiar with the ways of outsiders. I... do not know the proper customs for greeting newcomers to our society."

Cassiel hops forward on one foot and smiles cheerfully. "In that case, why not show us around? Someone else can go let the Founder know that we've arrived, and we can check out the sights on the way!"

"Cass..." Samantha grumbles at her but shrugs it off. "Well, I must admit I am curious about what's going on here, and how you arrived here."

Norek's polite deference weakens, and a look of consternation replaces it. "I am not a learned scholar. I merely ensure that an adequate supply of nutrition is available for all Branches, including my own. For matters regarding our history, none would be better to speak with than her grace, Dosena, or anyone in the Information Branch, for that matter."

All of us stand awkwardly for a few moments before Norek quickly turns around and beckons for us to follow. We carefully maintain our composure and try to act as regal as possible (Cassiel somehow pulls this off better than Samantha and I, likely because of her angelic presence), all while the villagers look on. Norek leads us past the congregated people, and one of the younger Volgrim children mutters to another, "...the statue man."

I glance at Cassiel and Samantha, but neither of them heard the child. "Norek," I say, quickening my pace to catch up to him, "One of those young ones said something about a 'statue man.' What's that about?"

He rubs his hands together slowly and considers the question for a moment. "Well, I am not certain of what they are referring to, as we have several statues, however, given the fact that you are a human, they may be referring to The Man In the Crystal. It has been many millennia since I completed my primary education, but I recall seeing his encased form in the Administration Branch once or twice. Thinking back on those memories, you might resemble him in some manner, though the hue of your skin and your glowing tattoos are substantially different from his. I wouldn't pay the rumors such heed. All humans look alike to a Volgrim, as the legends say."

"The man in the crystal, huh? I'll have to check into that while I'm here." I slow my walking to fall back to the girls, who are busy whispering to each other. I nudge Samantha subtly and keep my voice low as we pass rows of houses, all built out of a rather ugly mottled looking wood I haven't seen before. "Sam. Have you noticed? Nobody is panicking about Ionis. That's a good sign."

She breaks off from whatever she was talking to Cassiel about. "Perhaps. Based on what Cass and I have noticed, most of the Volgrim around here are rather young. It's likely they were born long after the Energy Wars, and whatever event caused them to settle here. Knowledge of the Sentinels might not be widespread. Also..." She smiles at a young male as we walk past and waves at him with just her fingers. The boy, in return, smiles, and waves back.

She reverts to a neutral expression once we've passed him. "...these Volgrim are acting very odd. Smiling, for instance, like that young one just now. I've met with these aliens on many occasions, and as far as I know, they do not give birth as humans do, nor do they have birthing pods as the demons do. From what I know, they create new Volgrim inside of special machines and rapidly age them, then infuse them with the knowledge to instantly push them into Volgrim society. But look around us. Everything here is built from wood, even the farming implements. Something isn't adding up."

Cassiel's expression turns serious. "You're wondering where their technology is, right, Sammy?"

"Yes." Samantha looks past me, subtly moving her head to tell me to look that way. When I do, I see a dozen male Volgrim all working together to chop a block of wood together... with wooden axes. Samantha smiles faintly, "I'm guessing there's no metal on this planet, and they don't have a way of obtaining any. I think they aren't here by choice."

A strange coldness frosts over the top layer of my skin. *This place has many mysteries. The entire planet should be an uproar because of our appearance, but everyone is treating us as if we aren't even that special. It's a little disconcerting.*

Half an hour later...

We leave behind the soft grass from the fields of the 'Supply and Labor Branch' and begin to walk on paved roads. Well, they're somewhat like paved roads. The pavement is made of wood, carefully and meticulously chopped into hundreds, thousands, even tens of thousands of blocks, and interlocked around every building to provide a smooth path. My feet *clomp* audibly with every step I take, and all around us, people are beginning to notice the five of us. Unlike the workers in the fields, these Volgrim stop and stare, some with fear in their eyes, others with burning curiosity.

The buildings around us are square cubes, apparently built entirely for functionality. Front yards, carvings on the walls, vehicles, none of the things that might give a house its distinctive 'personality' are present. Each house is only a floor or three tall, and there's barely any room between them for a single person to fit in the 'alley' dividing the buildings. The only way I can even tell they're houses is due to the door openings in front of each, where one can walk in and out, but no actual 'door' is present. Rectangles are merely cut into each one as if simple things like hinges and springs aren't available to make a door open and close.

I inquire about this to Norek, and he replies, "Volgrim do not need privacy."

Well, that isn't much of an answer.

Our Volgrim tour guide isn't one for flowery descriptions or rich explanations, but he describes in a few words that this is one of many Residential Branches under the authority of a female Volgrim who, surprisingly, he seems to admire. Elinia is her name, and apparently, she is the one who came up with the most efficient housing design to put as many Volgrim in as little space as possible. Personal space, on this world, is a luxury and a commodity, not a right.

Once we pass through the Residential Branch, we arrive in an area more densely packed with children and teenage Volgrim. Cassiel and I, though not Samantha, are both surprised at how the young ones act. They calmly walk through the streets, talking among one another, never

running or showing any outward hostility or aggression. "We inculcate the values of respect for authority and firmly reject outward displays of emotion in the early years, though those rules become laxer as the children are phased into their permanent roles," Norek explains helpfully.

Despite this, some children stare at us, and especially Cassiel, with looks of awe and admiration. Sometimes, when I catch them staring at her, an odd feeling of jealousy bubbles up in me, only to be replaced with a deep respect. Cassiel is truly a beautiful woman, in spite of what Gressil did to her, and she manages to hold herself with grace and poise. Samantha, for once, shows relief that she isn't the center of male attention.

"Isn't it a little creepy how the men stare at you, Cass?" Samantha asks, "I got used to their gazes after a very long time, but this is the first I've seen you have to deal with it."

Cassiel waves at a little girl, hardly seven years old by human terms. "Oh, not at all! The smiles on their faces are so pure and innocent. I almost think they're looking up to me like a mother."

A wistful smile on her face fades away. I almost get the impression she's thinking *I wish I had a child of my own*.

Norek interrupts our thoughts. "We've almost arrived. The Administration Branch is the center of Voldarius. The Great Sage, leader of our people, Founder Dosenia, will see you there. I am sure she has received word of the four mysterious visitors already, as I sent a messenger ahead to inform her."

"That was... um... thoughtful of you." Samantha coughs the words out, then glances at me. I can almost read her thoughts. *If Dosenia knows we're coming, we could be walking into a trap.*

Heh. *Maybe*. Then again, I see no evidence this planet could fight off an angry horde of cavemen from ancient Earth, let alone a demigod, an overpowered angel, and an emperor of the demons. Oh, and the death robot. Yeah, him too.

As if passing through a magical divider, the Education Branch's schools and universities are suddenly replaced with tall, multi-story buildings. Aside from a door at the bottom, each one has dozens of holes in the walls for each floor, not big enough to be windows; probably they were built to let light inside. Without electricity, I wonder if all their light comes from candles? That must be pretty dangerous in skyscrapers made entirely of wood.

No sooner have we passed through the first row of multistory 'skyscrapers' (Very pitiful ones at that), than we suddenly spot something that makes my jaw drop. A castle made entirely of wood. Unlike every building up to this point, the castle stands out for its beauty, turning the ugly mottled timber that every other building has used so far into a work of art. Carefully rounded edges are sanded together in a form not unlike the Taj Mahal, with round spires that

stretch into the sky, and the face of a Volgrim carved into the wall above a giant doorway leading inside. I'm not certain whose image the carving is etched, but if I had to guess, I would assume it was Dosena's.

Cassiel gazes around as we pass through a gated wall surrounding the entire structure. "Wow. This place is incredible."

For once, Norek smiles at her, a sincere expression I haven't seen him come close to using until just now. "I thank you for your words of kindness. I have played a small role in the creation of the great sage's quarters. Beyond myself, thousands of far more talented Volgrim artisans and crafters had their hand in making this wonder. We do not usually care for gaudy displays or functionless designs, but a wise individual once gave us words of wisdom."

He doesn't elaborate, so I prod him carefully. "And those were?"

Norek stares forward as we pass through the gates and enter the palace. "Sometimes, you must put heart and soul into the place you revere most, lest you begin to think it unimportant as time passes. Love and caring can make a house, a home."

"Huh." Cassiel taps her chin thoughtfully. "That doesn't sound very Volgrim-y. Who came up with that?"

Norek stops walking for a moment, a frown on his face. "I don't know. In fact, nobody does. Strange." With a sigh, he continues walking.

Now that we're in the heart of this planet's headquarters, the mood is very different. Gone are the smiles and looks of awe and admiration. Now, as we walk down halls and through doors, Volgrim freeze where they stand, terror and panic on every face. One thing is shared among every look of dread; every frightened Volgrim fixates entirely on Ionis.

Samantha, agitation in her body language, nudges me. "I think we've found the Volgrim in the 'know,' love."

"No kidding."

We round a final corner through a narrow doorway, and Norek stops just inside, bowing, which keeps me from entering without having to shove past him. "Wise sage, great Founder of our people, as you may have already heard, we have visitors from... somewhere else. I have brought them here since they have requested to see you."

Though I can see around the corner to where she is, I hear her voice loud and clear. "Very good, Brother Norek. I thank you for your astute diplomacy. Bring them in."

Norek bows a little deeper, then steps inside, allowing us to enter single-file.

I walk through the door and finally spot her. Dosena sits in a large ornate wooden chair, likely where she spends much of her day doing administrative duties. Her pure black hair falls on her shoulders, like a fairy sleeping peacefully, while her narrowed eyes indicate a cunning gaze, and her pale white skin contrasts with her cherry red lips. Only when she opens her mouth to greet me is the visage of a beautiful woman broken by those horrifying shark-like teeth.

"Human male, I am Dosena, Founder of the Volgrim." Her eyes turn to slits as she evaluates me. "You look... very familiar."

She doesn't dwell on me much. Cassiel walks in, bows clumsily, and almost falls over. Dosena gestures lightly with her hand. "There is no need for displays of humility among honored guests. It has been too long since we've seen a face that doesn't belong to a Volgrim, let alone-" She pauses, as Samantha enters next, "-let alone a human, angel, and demon. I can scarcely believe my eyes." She stands up from her chair, baring her teeth in an animalistic 'smile.' "After being stranded here all these years, it would seem your species have finally united together. Now you need only a Volgrim representative to complete the group."

Samantha's expression is serious. "Yeah... about that."

The words have scarcely left her lips, before Ionis steps through the doorway, his enormous frame scraping the wooden ceiling above.

All the color drains from Dosena's face. Her smile slowly morphs into a look of terror.

Then, she screams.

Howard quacks.

Part 437c: War Never Changes

"Aaaaaiieeehh!!"

A horrible scream, one that might curdle milk if I were holding any, blasts out of Dosena's mouth, as she leaps backward in fright, toppling over her chair and falling on her back. An instant later, before I can try to calm her down, an invisible force smashes my body against the wall behind me with fifty times the might of Earth's gravity. Like a silent hurricane, my body is crushed between visible and invisible materials of the universe. My head is wrenched to the side, and I realize Samantha is also being pressed against the wall beside me, and likely Cassiel as well. The look of pain on Samantha's face boils my blood.

And then the objects come. Wooden utensils, furniture, and a thousand other tiny things begin spinning around in a maelstrom, then blasting out and racing somewhere I can't see. Using all my strength, I jerk my head to the side as a wooden knife races at my face. It stabs into the wall, a millimeter from my nose, and I can't even gasp in relief. The pressure on my body is unthinkable.

I struggle mightily and turn my head to the other side, confirming that Cassiel is also slammed against the wall... but also that Ionis hasn't budged an inch. The tornado of telekinesis doesn't affect him at all. Utensils and a torrent of other items fly at the Sentinel, but he stands like a boulder against a raging river, unmoving.

Finally, I've had enough. " **Stop!** "

Immediately, the hurricane of psionics ceases, and three simultaneous *whumps* hit the ground as the girls and I fall to the floor. Gasping for breath, I look over at Dosena to see that she looks confused and terrified. The room looks like a bomb went off, the walls behind us have depressions from our bodies, and crap has been thrown all over the goddamn place.

Dosena squints hard, trying to summon her power from seconds before, but nothing happens. Giving up, she pulls herself from the floor, looks at me, then at Ionis, before looking back. "I can't use my telekinesis. What did you do?" Her regal demeanor and tone of voice from earlier is gone. She's bedraggled, her hair is a mop, and her robes are torn everywhere. If this was my first impression of her, I'd assume she was an insane woman.

"I sealed your power, for now. I assume you exploded like that because of Ionis-"

"What in the name of the Seven Ghark Riders are you thinking?! That's a Sentinel!" Dosena cuts me off, stabbing a finger through the air at Ionis. "You've awoken the harbinger of the galaxy's destruction!"

"Oh my god! Howard!" Cassiel yells out in alarm behind me, pulling my attention away for a moment. By the time I turn around, whatever happened to the duck has already been fixed. Cassiel wipes her forehead in relief as the duck glares at me. "Oh, sorry. I healed him. Never mind!"

"I'm glad the duck is fine, Cass." I turn back to Dosena. "Anyway. I didn't activate Ionis. He was already online when I found him."

Dosena's eyes continue to flit from Ionis to me and back. "Is that so? And just how long have the Sentinels been online, in that case?"

Samantha nudges me, pulling my attention away from the Volgrim leader. "I'll explain. You weren't around for it, after all."

Minutes pass, and Samantha carefully explains the Energy Wars to Dosena. Gradually, the female Volgrim realizes that Ionis has been entirely passive the whole time, and she loses a small amount of the tenseness in her shoulders, even going so far as to step away from the corner of the room and pull her hair back.

"...so, at that point, Hero looked through the files and located you." Samantha finishes, and Dosena's eyes narrow.

"He found me? How do you mean?"

"I have... abilities. Much as you do. They enabled me to disable yours, and also for me to locate you. It's a little complex."

Weirdly, Dosena stares at me for several long moments. "Wordsmithing. The ability to create anything you wish with the power of a single word." She pauses, "Judging by that look on your face, I'm correct."

My shock vanishes quickly. "How did you guess? That was a little too specific to be a random stab in the dark."

"Volgrim can read minds. Well, highly evolved ones can, anyway." She smirks at me, and I shoot a look of annoyance at Samantha.

My cute succubus tosses her hands in the air. "What? I didn't know that! I'm as surprised as you!"

Dosena twirls a few hairs around her finger. "You sealed my telekinesis, but not my telepathy. I suppose your power has limitations. Good to know."

"Not many," I growl, cursing myself for underestimating her. "Let's move on. Ionis wants to see you because he plans to rebuild the Sentinels. Obviously, the three of us are opposed, but he's supposed to be an invincible killer robot, so telling him 'no' seemed a bad idea."

The Volgrim commander stares at me blankly. Several long seconds pass, and then she does something out of left field. She chuckles. The quiet titter speeds up, rises into a crescendo and transforms into full-blown laughter as she wheezes for breath. Finally matching her disheveled appearance, Dosena cackles like a witch with a mental disorder for a whole minute straight, until she suddenly stops.

"Absolutely not. You can torture or kill me, but I'll never assist a Sentinel. I assure you, even if you spent the next thousand years trying to break me, I'd never budge. It's a waste of time.

Before I can retort, she holds up a finger. "It's pointless, anyway. Cuanali was the genius who created the Sentinels. She was murdered by another of our kind, though the fool's name evades me. I had nothing to do with their creation, and only a minor role in helping to stop them. Now that the Sentinels are back, nothing can stop-" Her voice catches, suddenly. "Hold a moment. If this... Ionis... if he needs to 'rebuild' the Sentinels, what happened to the other ones?"

Ionis blares into my mind, *THIS ORGANIC UNIT WAS RESPONSIBLE FOR THEIR DESTRUCTION. HE WILL REBUILD THEM.*

Despite speaking only to me, Ionis's words make Dosena look at him. "Is that so?"

"You can hear him too?"

She nods, "Something like that. I'm continually reading your mind, so when he spoke to you, I heard it loud and clear. Funny... I don't remember the Sentinels having telepathic abilities. It would be quite dangerous if he had mutated or evolved new... *features*."

"Can you stop reading my mind?"

"Yes."

"Thank you."

"I didn't say I was going to, I merely stated it was within my capabilities to do so."

"Oh my *god*. Stop reading my mind, or I'll seal your telepathic abilities too."

That seems to convince her. "Fine. Can we move on? You came here looking to rebuild the Sentinels, but that will be impossible. Even if I had the technology, which I don't, Cuanali was the lead scientist who created the Sentinels. Without her genius mind, it's impossible to recreate them. Even if it *were* possible, I wouldn't do it."

I glance at Ionis. "Hear that? It's impossible. What now? You gonna kill us?"

Ionis says nothing for several seconds, then his eye tilts down to stare at the floor. *I AM ALONE. WHY DID YOU DISASSEMBLE THE SENTINELS?*

"I didn't! Stop saying I did, stupid robot! I don't know why you think I'm responsible, but it's seriously starting to piss me off."

Everyone stays silent for a few moments, the girls mostly because they have no idea what Ionis is saying, and Dosena because she is deep in thought. Finally, she raises her head to look at me, a determined expression on her face. "Why don't we take a walk?"

"Huh? Why?" Cassiel retorts, "What's that going to accomplish?"

"Just come with me." Dosena walks over and pushes past us, sliding as close to the wall as possible to avoid Ionis in the doorway.

A few minutes later, the five of us stroll out into an inner courtyard of the castle. A large pond is in the center, surrounded by wooden benches where a dozen or so Volgrim males and females congregate, quietly chatting among each other. On a ledge nearby, a distinctly Earthlike bird, possibly a Finch, chirps sweetly. Seeing the bird stirs misgivings inside me about the way this tiny planet works, but I quietly keep those thoughts to myself, as our group stops in front of the pond.

Dosena blushes, "Thank you for repairing my clothing with your magic. I apologize that you had to see me in such an undignified state."

"It was my pleasure. Seeing a Sentinel was probably the biggest heart attack you've had in your life."

She nods, melancholy clouding her face, "If only you knew. Be glad you weren't there. The guilt of what we did nearly tore our entire species apart."

Curiosity takes hold, as my feet press down on the neatly trimmed grass. "You mean regarding the creation of the Sentinels?"

"Mmm." Dosena glances behind me at Samantha. "You seem to be the most learned one here. What do you know about them?"

Samantha shrugs. "Other than they're extremely efficient at killing humans and Volgrim? Not much."

"I see." Dosena sits on a bench and gestures for us to sit one another opposite her. We do, though Ionis continues to stand and stare, which makes us feel awkward, especially when the other Volgrim in the courtyard spot him. "The people in the Administrative Branch are among the oldest members of our kind. They, as well as myself, were apparently here when we were stranded on this... *object*." Dosena's eyes narrow as she stares at the ground in thought. "One thing we became acutely aware of was the missing memories- but I'm getting ahead of myself. I should explain the Sentinels first."

Cassiel smiles sweetly. "If you want, I'll let you hold Howard. He helps me think and remember things. He's a therapy duck!"

"That explains a few things," Samantha murmurs under her breath. Cass doesn't hear her.

"The creature is quite adorable, but that won't be necessary." Dosena waggles a finger back and forth on her knee, "It started during the Great Wars. The Volgrim were once a brutal, violent, yet 'democratic' race. Everything was handled via votes. Every labor shortage, every military endeavor, anything involving the nutrition economy, as well as what to do with the rejects of society. This system created much division among the members of any given faction when the votes didn't go their way. As such, over time, a silent war began to brew. I was not on the side of the ruling class, in fact, I was a warrior among one of the smaller tribes."

"The first Great War, of which seven such wars occurred in a million years, was caused by something trifling. I don't recall what it was now, but I think it was regarding a tax that affected a marginalized group. Until that point, military activity, for all tribes, was minimal at best. Certainly, many powerful weapons existed, but their usage was considered barbaric. The military's main purpose was to quash and quell minor insurrections. The Great Wars changed that. Each one was exceedingly worse than the last. Ten million Volgarians died in the first. Fifty million in the next. By the third, there were ten tribes split among our people. Two of them perished. Our planet was small, perhaps the size of humanity's homeworld, but rich in resources."

I roll my eyes, annoyed. "This all sounds familiar to me. Humanity has some parallels."

"Possibly. The Fourth Great War was when a major change occurred. We discovered a rare deposit of metal when we located a small planet a thousand lightyears from our homeworld. It had deposits of a metal not known of before, which was later coined 'Living Moldanium'. Unfortunately, the tribe that discovered it gained unthinkable power, since the metal was resistant to most forms of damage. They created a series of facilities in a region known as Melkia, and those facilities were used to create machines that were all but impervious to damage."

Cassiel's jaw drops, "The Sentinels?"

Dosena shakes her head, a wry smile on her face. "No. Those came later. The Fifth great war was a turning point. My tribe, then the third biggest of five remainders, had begun to experiment with adapting our bodies. Reflexes, eyesight, removing the need for nutrition... anything went. Had these experiments occurred during peacetime, the advancements would have no-doubt advanced the overall quality of life for all Volgrim. We were certain of this. In any case, the ones you know as the 'Founders' were nothing special at first. Some might have

glorified us with titles such as 'Freedom Fighters', but we were merely individuals fighting to survive."

"Given that Cuanali was the genius of our group, she gave us a glimmer of hope. If we could take control of just one Moldanium facility, she could utilize the metal to create a new weapon, one that was a weapon of peace. Artificial juggernauts. Unbiased peacekeepers."

Cassiel bites her lip uneasily, "And *those* were the Sentinels... right?"

"Yes. We succeeded in taking the facility at Melkian IV. It was a violent, brutal fight, but we succeeded. However, time was running short. Cuanali confessed that she hadn't the time to create perfect AI while the military of the largest branch was advancing on our position, so she took a few shortcuts. At the time, we thought nothing of it, but those were the worst mistakes we ever made. Instead of creating AI, Cuanali asked for Volunteers. She would transmit the minds of our smartest military leaders and personnel into the machines, while also attempting to correct for personal biases and cognitive deficiencies. Effectively, whoever volunteered was giving their life for the cause."

"Surprisingly, many volunteered. As I said, some people thought of themselves as heroes, fighting to save the lives of their fellow Volgrim. Perhaps the fame went to their heads. I do not know. Cuanali assured us that she would be able to 'wash' enough of their personal preferences from the systems that they would be the unbiased machines we wished, but we overestimated her genius."

Samantha looks up uneasily at Ionis, still standing and staring at us. "So the Sentinels took over and killed everyone, huh? Maybe we shouldn't be saying this in front of the death-machine?"

Dosena shakes her head. "No, you're wrong. Everything went exactly as planned, *at first*. We mopped up the army of the biggest tribe, and the Sentinels began their 'peacekeeping,' just as we had intended. However, this immediately began the Sixth Great War. Many Volgrim opposed the use of artificial constructs to 'maintain peace', as we assured them, and what we did not realize was that the Sentinels were still learning. The constant surprise attacks by guerrilla attackers, useless though they were, only served to anger the Sentinels. In the first five wars, Volgrim fought Volgrim. In the sixth, Sentinel fought Volgrim. But... in the Seventh... the Seventh..."

Dosena trails off, and a hollowness appears in her eyes. "Many died. Ninety percent of the Volgrim population, as I recall. There was no hope. We hadn't a chance of stopping the Sentinels, once they had taken over our communications. They were all but impervious to damage, and while they couldn't build more of themselves, they began to adapt their bodies to

improve their fighting capabilities. A hundred Sentinels were enough to pacify a population of trillions."

Cassiel pets Howard slowly. "But you did win, right? Did you destroy them? Or stop them? Or something?"

"I *suppose* you could call it a win. You see, at the time, our most brilliant figurehead, Unarin, was leading us along a path of body improvement unlike any before. We had already mastered some forms of psionic energy... but he had somehow tapped into something inexplicable. He described a sea of energy, previously unseen, which allowed him to do things like create fire from his hands. At first, they were just neat parlor tricks, but he explained to us that given time, we could still salvage our civilization. He planned to become invisible, sneak into the heart of the Sentinel base, the facility at Melkian IV, and somehow disable them. He had yet to come up with a way to do so, but as usual, Cuanali solved that problem for us."

Dosena grips her robes tightly. "We sacrificed fifty thousand comrades to create a new artificial intelligence, in total secrecy. Good friends, companions, and colleagues, all chosen at random via an awful lottery. None complained. They were going to die to the Sentinels if they didn't anyway, so at least this meant they could ensure our survival. Every last one of them was a hero. Cuanali spent twenty years perfecting the algorithm, all while more of us were purged. Eventually, she finished her greatest creation yet; The Gatekeeper. Unarin, through a brilliant mission of espionage, installed the Gatekeeper onto a server that all Sentinels accessed regularly, and within ten minutes, they were disabled."

The three of us breathe a sigh of relief, and I finally offer my thoughts. "So you couldn't destroy them, but you were able to shut them down? Why not disassemble them afterward?"

"They adapted," Dosena says, "so we couldn't. Joints, gaps in the armor, all of it gone. There isn't a single way to destroy a Sentinel. Shutting them down was our only recourse."

I peep uneasily over at Ionis. "But according to this guy... I killed the Sentinels. All of them except for him. Say, Ionis, how did I destroy the other Sentinels, if you're so sure I did it? And if I destroyed them, what makes you think I cannot kill you?"

Ionis pivots his eye at me. His voice sounds... *shakier* than usual. *INFORMATION REGARDING HOW YOU DESTROYED THE SENTINELS IS UNAVAILABLE. I HAVE CLASSIFIED YOUR THREAT LEVEL AS MAXIMUM AS A RESULT.*

Dosena blinks twice, "Maximum? That's incredible. When we learned about how they would classify targets based on threat levels, our first-"

Cutting her off mid-sentence, I glare at the Volgrim Leader. "Hey! I told you to stay out of my head!"

"Apologies. I must have forgotten." She smirks at me in a way that says *actually, I didn't*. Whatever. Dosena continues, "This is all beside the point. Obviously, someone brought the Sentinels back for some unknown purpose. It was likely Unarin. After the Seventh War, when we managed to shut them down, Unarin pledged to put an end to all wars forever. He used his oratory skills and incredible influence to create an almost mythical persona about himself, as if he had slain them in direct combat. Truth be told, only a few hundred of us knew the truth, that they couldn't be destroyed, and were always a threat, so he forced all Volgrim to evacuate the planet and search for a new home. Then, he implemented his final two acts, which would bury our past, forever."

Dosena doesn't elaborate. Samantha bobs her head, then realizes more information isn't forthcoming. "Uh, so what did he do next?"

Dosena blinks quickly, as if she had been lost in memory. "Ah, sorry. He used his powers to create a gas that would pervade our entire planet, devouring all biological material and rendering it inhospitable. This was to ensure that nobody stayed on Volgarius in secret and ever discovered the Sentinels. After that, he forcibly brainwashed all members of our species, except for the five Founders."

"What?! That's terrible!" Cassiel bursts out angrily, a terrible scowl on her face. "So he gassed anyone still living on the surface, then he turned the rest into mindless slaves?! How could you go along with that?!"

"Nobody should have been on Volgarius. If anyone died, it was their own fault," Dosena explains coolly. "As for the brainwashing, I can see how primitives might misinterpret his actions, but I assure you, it was for the good of our people. Individuality and emotions cripple a species. It's better for the truly enlightened to lead, while the less brilliant fall into line."

Samantha is unconvinced. "So you have the smart lead the stupid, huh? And what individual decides who is smart and who is stupid?"

Dosena stands up and brushes dust from her robes. "Now now, coming from a demon, that is rather hypocritical, wouldn't you say? Your species is all about 'might makes right,' after all. And the angels, they were led by those who claimed to have divine providence. Every society has its foibles, and for the Volgrim, unending war for a million years was as good a reason as any to try something new. It worked out rather well."

Samantha chuckles, "Until the Energy Wars."

"Until the Energy Wars," Dosena echoes. "But that's a discussion for another time. Come with me once more, I have something you should see."

The girls and I look at each other, shrug and stand up to follow her. Walking past the beautiful pond, several Volgrim stare silently, first at Ionis, then at Dosena, trying to figure out why a Sentinel is in their midst, and why she isn't panicked. *It must not be dangerous*, I can almost hear them thinking, *because if it were, Dosena would be telling us to flee*.

"Dosena, why do some of the Volgrim here know about Sentinels, while others don't? How did you end up on this planet?"

We exit the garden and stroll toward the front of the castle, where we first arrived from. Dosena glances back at me, a hardened look in her eyes. "I don't know. Or rather, I don't remember. Nobody does. There's a hollow spot in our memory, and it extends to several other areas of our lives."

Cassiel pokes Dosena's left shoulder. "So where were you before you came here? Remember anything about that?"

The Volgrim commander is silent for several moments, as we exit the palace and head down the path toward the city, but this time take a left before we leave the palace walls. "Vaguely. In the back of my mind, I recall a strange sense of betrayal. I remember that I was in a group of Volgrim- and I believe demons were there too. We were..." She turns her head slightly to look at Cassiel, worry on her face. "...we were attacking the angels."

"What? Why?!" Cassiel is aghast now, more so than when she heard about the Volgrim brainwashing their own people. "What did the angels do to you?"

"Um." Dosena's hard expression turns sheepish, "I don't remember. It's been so long. What I do remember is that, for some reason, Unarin left us to die. The gas that he unleashed upon Volgarius was unleashed a second time. Somehow, we escaped, then we ended up here, on this object."

Now it's my turn to interrupt, "You keep calling this planet an 'object.' Why?"

She scoffs, "It's not a planet, human. Not by any stretching of the definition. One thing has been confirmed many times over, that we live on an artificial sphere outside of the void we were born. We exist on a plane different from the original, though it is difficult to put in words."

I nod, "You live in another dimension, you mean? I know that much is true."

"You took the words from my mouth." Dozena leads us into a building resembling a temple, and beckons toward... a giant crystal.

My heart slams in my chest, and the girls both gasp. It takes a few seconds, but Cassiel speaks, her voice a whisper. "The- the resemblance. It's uncanny."

"Is that *me*?" I walk forward and examine the crystal. Inside is a human male, frozen as if he's been put into suspended animation, ready to awaken at any moment.

Dosena nods sagely. "I wanted to come here and confirm with my eyes. You do somewhat resemble this human. He is one of our biggest mysteries."

Words escape me. I rap my knuckles on the crystal, and the sound is a rock-solid *thud*. "Uh... can you- can you wake him up?"

"No. He is dead. Crystallization is something the Volgrim can do, but it is reserved for those of high honor. If I were to die, the other members of Voldarius would crystallize me, but this is not the case for ninety-nine percent of my people. One must do something truly incredible to deserve such an honor."

My eyes turn to her uneasily, "So what did, uh, *this guy* do? Me, I suppose? And who is he?"

I close my eyes as my thoughts run wild. *Did one of my clones survive and come here? Impossible. Hope? Unlikely. How did he end up here, and why?*

Dosena's tongue snakes out and wets her lips. "We collected vague recollections of memories from everyone alive at the time for our hard-bound archives. This world is artificial, and the way we came here is a mystery. Seeing you arrive here now, along with knowledge of your power, and the image of this crystallized human, I believe I can finally fill in the gaps."

"And?" Samantha verbally nudges her.

"I believe Unarin betrayed us. I don't know why, but it fits. He left us to die, but a savior appeared, pulled us from the realm of angels, and created a new world for us to live, peacefully. That savior... was you, Hero. Or possibly someone with an uncanny resemblance to you. This explains why after he died, we crystallized him. The only remaining mystery is what erased our memories after his death, and why we don't remember crystallizing him."

"Well," I say, tapping my lips, "Not the *only* mystery. There's also why the hell he looks exactly like me. This had to have happened millions of years ago, right?"

"Correct."

So it couldn't be me, my mind thinks, yet at the same time...

I glance over at Ionis. "You said I destroyed the Sentinels, correct?"

Ionis doesn't move. *AFFIRMATIVE. YOU ARE DIRECTLY RESPONSIBLE FOR THE DESTRUCTION OF THE SENTINELS.*

"That was millions of years ago too, right?"

AFFIRMATIVE.

"I see," I turn back to Dosena, "Whoever this person is, whether he's me, or a twin brother I knew nothing about, he must have been responsible for both things. He destroyed the Sentinels, he created this planet, and he saved you from the rest of the Volgrim."

A second thought creeps into my mind, but I dare not say it out loud. *What if he is the original, and... I'm the clone?*

Samantha smiles toothily, "You put it together! So smart!"

"You're a genius!" Cassiel says, her smile radiant like the star in the sky. "But, um... I have a question for you, Dosena."

"Go ahead, angelic one."

Cassiel blushes slightly, "It's kind of a stupid question, but... why is the word 'Pickle' engraved at the bottom of the statue?"

"Huh?" I take a step back and look down. Sure enough, engraved on the wood platform this human sits upon, is the lone word 'Pickle'. "What the actual fuck?"

Dosena nods sagely once more. "We have presumed, given our limited understanding of the human vocabulary, that it was this human's name. The name of a mighty warrior, perhaps, or that of a person with godlike powers. Was our supposition incorrect?"

I glance at Cassiel, then at Samantha. "Uh. No. That's, um, completely correct. A mighty warrior... ha... haha..."

Samantha snickers, "Maybe he named himself that for personal reasons."

"Augh! That's nasty, Sam!"

"Jeez, I'm just saying."

* * *

Hours later, the girls and I, followed by Ionis, stand in the open field once more. Dosena and a vast crowd of her fellow Volgrim stare at us, longing in their eyes. Surrounding us, a mile in every direction, are all one hundred thousand of the Volgrim living on this rock. Many watch with interest, others with no curiosity whatsoever, but many wear their thoughts on their faces. *I wonder where these visitors will return to?*

"I could create a portal and help you return to Volgrim space," I offer helpfully.

Dosena shakes her head, "No... no, human, that is not necessary. It has been a hundred million years. The Volgrim out there are as alien to me as, well, as you three are. Even assuming they accepted us back, reintegration would be difficult and painful. Having brought back the

emotions we once buried, I do not wish to return to such a hivemind as what Unarin envisioned."

"I understand," I say, accepting her choice. "However, there is no reason you should have to live in squalor. Perhaps I can build a machine for you that will allow you to come and go to the normal universe as you please? Maybe I can summon a bunch of metal so you can at least have better tools, or whatever?"

The leader of the Volgrim smiles at me, a radiant expression that doesn't irk me as it did before. Even the strange shark-teeth don't bother me. Perhaps I've grown used to them. "That is very kind and generous of you. No doubt you have the same honest heart that Pickle did. If I could ask just one thing of you, it would be that you do not forget about us." She blushes and looks away, rubbing her hands together. "You are free to come and go from here as you please."

Her sudden warmth toward me makes me feel a little bashful. "Thanks, I won't forget you."

A male Volgrim steps forward, one I met earlier when she was showing me around the castle. Elder Yonkin, one of her top advisors. "My lady, I beg a moment of your time before our visitors leave."

The girls and I wait as Yonkin pulls her away, to whisper to her, and a minute later, she returns, her smile gone. "Hero, I almost forgot something essential. I've been so caught up in our reminiscing, that I didn't ask a very pressing question on my mind."

Immediately, I know what she's going to ask. "Ionis?"

"Yes. Now that you know what you know, what are you going to do? He has made no hostile moves, but he *is* a Sentinel. You cannot trust this... this machine."

Ionis stands silently beside me, and I feel off-put by talking about him as if he isn't there. I turn to him. "Ionis. We now know rebuilding the Sentinels is impossible. What are you going to do now that you know this fact?"

No response. For a full minute, everyone stares at the robot silently, as his eye slowly spins around his head, examining each one-by-one.

I AM ALONE.

"Yes."

A tone in his robotic voice sounds different from how it usually does.

NO OTHER SENTINELS CAN BE CREATED.

"That's right."

He lowers his head. *I HAVE NO PURPOSE. POINTS ARE USELESS WITHOUT A COMPARISON.*

Again with this 'points' talk. I swear, AI makes no sense. "I suppose not."

I... I WILL DO NOTHING. I WILL OBSERVE.

Huh. Well, can't complain, it's better than killing everything in his path.

"I can work with that." Turning to Dosena, I smile, "You know, when you told me about the Sentinels, do you remember what you said? You said that they began killing Volgrim outside of the original parameters because the Volgrim held intense hatred toward them. It created a vicious cycle that never ended."

Dosena narrows her eyes, "What do you mean?"

Cassiel squeezes Howard a little harder. "Hero means that violence will never put an end to the cycle of violence. Only patience and understanding can heal a wound. Unarin brainwashing his people was a band-aid, not a practical solution. He never solved the problem, and only buried it, just as he buried your history. He looked for a quick-fix, and found it. All these years later, humanity is subjugated, and a Great War among the remaining species is on the horizon again. The solution has to come from a place of understanding, not a place of hatred."

Dosena nods slowly, "I see. The three of you are wise. I... I wish... I wish people like you had been there at the end of our wars. Perhaps things would have turned out differently."

Samantha rubs her shoulders, "We're not perfect. We're just doing what we can."

I turn around to open the portal, but Dosena rests a hand on my shoulder. "If you can put an end to the violence, that is what you should do. Your power is unlike anything ever witnessed before in the history of the universe. Used for evil, it could destroy us all, but used for good, it could be everyone's salvation. I ask only that you try to end the suffering and hate."

"I'll do what I can," I say, not wanting to commit so easily. *It's one thing to make a promise, but another to keep it. Especially when that promise is peace, and I have so much blood on my hands.*

Pulling away from her, I speak to the void, aiming my mind at the ship and the magical beacon I placed on it. " **Portal.** "

A giant hole in space opens up, and the three of us smile and wave. Samantha takes a quick step and kisses Dosena on the cheek. When Dosena stares at her questioningly, Samantha replies, "It's a sign of friendship."

We part ways, enter the portal, and leave Voldarius behind.

Part 438c: Surprise

The girls and I emerge from the Voldarian portal and step onto our ship's bridge, with Ionis popping through a second later. I seal the portal up and sigh. "I'm going to miss the feeling of grass under my feet."

"And sun in the sky," Samantha chimes in, as she slumps into her seat at the gunner's position.

"And the sound of birds chirping," Cassiel adds, "Howard had birdy friends! He was having the time of his life!" Cassiel sits in her navigator's chair, setting Howard on the ground and giving him a little pat on the head.

"Wark," quacks the duck, in a rather depressed tone. "Wark..."

"Maybe I should make him a duck girlfriend next?" I lean lightly on Cassiel's shoulder and stare at the navigator's console. "Hm? Where are we?"

Cassiel pauses at my question and scans the navigation console, a confused expression sprouting on her face. "Um. This can't be right. It says we're still in Terran space, just past Neptune's orbit."

The ship's alarm suddenly blares and Samantha nearly jumps out of her skin. She taps her display, which she's been learning to use, "Volgrim ships, dozens of them! We're surrounded!"

Cassiel's expression darkens, "We're caught in a Volikrov Net. It pulled our ship from hyperspace and stranded us here. It's an ambush!"

"Try and get us out of here, Cass. I'll make a portal back to Voldar-" Before I can take two steps away, nausea hits me, blanketing my entire body. My guts turn from a queasy jitter to a washing machine at max speed as waves of pain blast over my body, knocking out feeling in my legs. Dizzily, I trip and fall to the ground. Unable to move my arms to catch myself, my face smashes against the metal deckplate, battering me like a hammer to the skull.

Moments later, the sound of two other bodies hitting the deck catch up to me. Cassiel and Samantha. They've been hit too? I can barely think. Opening my eyes and blinking dozens of red patches away, I spot Samantha flopped lifelessly on the ground. Her body unmoving, she weakly coughs and whispers, "An... anti... anti-energy..."

What the fuck? The Volgrim! They caught us in a trap and hit us with anti-energy as soon as we came back!

Two webbed feet come into my vision, and Howard quacks several times, poking me in the nose with his bill. The anti-energy won't affect him, so all he knows is that we're down for the count, but not why. He can't even understand what's going on...

I can't fight back. I can't even move! They got us. I should have realized this would be an effective trap, but-

Wait! Ionis!

"Ion-" I cough and blood roils up from my innards, splashing out my mouth. "Ionis... where..."

Samantha, with a mighty effort, twitches her hand, trying to reach toward- no, she's reaching past me. "Cass... Cassiel..."

Shit. Cassiel is an angel. Anti-energy can kill her!

Where is Ionis?! I can't see him!

"Ionis... help us..."

Part 439c: Creeping Terror

Cautiously, I eye the battle plan for what must be the twenty-third time. "Elder Kryios, is the ambush in place?"

Kryios runs a finger through her black hair, and her holographic image fizzles for a moment as the time-lag catches up. "Yes, Elder Basil. You really must learn to be less anxious. Ten of our best commandos are in wait aboard their ship. Once we douse them with anti-energy, they'll be defenseless."

A deep wheeze escapes my rotund belly. "And- as for the Sentinel? You're certain it isn't-"

The female interrupts me. As always, Kryios never allows me to finish my thoughts. "The Sentinel is a fake. We've confirmed it's nowhere on their ship. Probably image manipulation or some such trickery, as we should expect from a human."

I nod uneasily, dabbing at my face with a cloth beside me. "We'll leave it to you, then."

The entire roomful of Council-members collectively sighs as Elder Kryios turns away from her holographic projector to speak to someone offscreen. Her image is being projected into the middle of the theater so that everyone can see and talk to her at once, but usually, they leave the discussion to myself and other influential Council-members.

Elder Lozu, one of my subordinates, leans back in his seat and turns to look at me. "I'm relieved. It's no wonder the succubus tried to bluff us. Their tiny crew is mortally vulnerable to anti-energy, so bombarding their ship with it was guaranteed to bring them to their knees."

"Mmm. I suppose so." Reaching to my side, I tap on a console to have one of the Council assistants bring me Kornk, a sweet concoction that suits my fancy. Other Volgrim eat and drink rarely, if ever, but I greatly enjoy the taste of food and drink. It's likely why my internal systems build up so much... *bulk*. "Even so, the fact is that there is likely a Sentinel somewhere in the galaxy. We've never been able to confirm its existence, but I saw the footage myself. It's probably in hiding, waiting to strike when we-"

"Ahh!" Elder Kryios shrieks, an awful noise that makes every member of the Council flinch in their seats. "Something just impacted one of our vessels encircled around the human ship. We're investigating n- what do you mean?!" She pauses, still speaking to someone outside of the holographic projector's range.

"Elder Kryios. A status update. What's going on?" One of the other Council-members leans forward, alarm on his face. "Are the humans fighting back?"

She turns to face her projector, irritation visible. "This is the worst-case scenario. You're all distracting me. Elder Kryios, out."

Her hologram vanishes, leaving everyone in the room to stare stonily where she had been just a moment before, cold sweat running down our backs.

"Get... get me a feed up! I want a readout on the situation from a third party. On the double!"

* * *

My hands shake, despite my nerves usually being like iron. This can't be possible! We checked their ship from top to bottom! No life signs were aboard, and there wasn't a spot on their spaceship where they could have stashed a Sentinel. Did they take it with them? We detected residual magic energy on their bridge, as well as a small tear in the fabric of space, so it's obvious they left the ship to go somewhere else, but we knew immediately they planned to come back.

So did they take the Sentinel with them? Why would the damned thing be active?! Do they have a death wish? Is it following their orders?!

"Elder Kryios," my first officer, Vili Jorrus, turns to me, panic on his face, "The object that impacted the V.S.S. Jinrex is still unknown. We've scoured security footage over the last minute, but we can't find out anything about it. Whatever hit the ship, it's invisible to all known visual spectrums."

"Have you scanned the interior? Infrared? Ultraviolet? Sonar?" I look at him, pleading with my eyes, but Jorrus shakes his head.

"If this is a Sentinel, we can't track it at all. Four-hundred crew-members have lost their lives already. The death toll is skyrocketing."

He's scarcely finished speaking when a terrific explosion erupts in the distance, several dozen kilometers from our ship's bow. I stare in disbelief as the V.S.S. Jinrex blasts apart into a trillion pieces, each piece of the vessel scattering to the far corners of the void.

"What- what just happened?"

Vili Jorrus taps a few buttons, and his gaze tightens. "The warp core was breached. Data transmitted at the last second indicates it was pierced in seven key areas simultaneously by a microscopic laser, detonating the unstable Trifrancium reserves all at once."

My tongue snakes out, wetting my lips. "Imagine that. Pinpoint precision, near-instant targeting of the ship's weak points. It has to be the Sentinel."

Jorrus slowly bows his head. "The demoness wasn't lying. We can't win against a Sentinel; we're doomed to fail. We need to retreat and cut our losses, immediately."

"Spawn of a Founder." Cursing under my breath, I quickly think about our tactical options. "If that machine is invisible, and we can't track it, a retreat is worse than useless. It can merely stow away on a ship until we come to a stop, and in fact, we may inadvertently ferry it to the new homeworld. It would be better for us to lose this entire system than to flee and bring the parasite with-

Another explosion in the distant reach of the void blinds me for a moment, before the fireball from the blast is extinguished by the vacuum of space.

Silently, Jorrus taps more buttons, then nods at our scanning officer. "Another warp core breach. This one took less time than the previous. The Sentinel is adapting, and it has quickly learned how our warp cores function."

I jump from my seat and start pacing around, unable to keep still. "If we die here, the Volgarian Empire loses over twenty percent of its reserve fleet. Unacceptable. The Kolvaxians will not give us respite, and we will lose the war with such a loss. What are my other options, Jorrus?"

The nervousness on his face betrays his suggestion before he says anything. "The human, demon, or the angel must have activated the Sentinel when we attacked them. If we remove the anti-energy and let them go, they might recall it."

"Oh, yes, I'll just ask them politely if they can disable the-" I'm cut off as another explosion destroys a third ship. "...Okay, we'll call that a 'maybe.' If we let them go, it may turn out they cannot recall the Sentinel. We don't know if it's following their orders or not. Worse, by letting them go, we lose them as prisoners, and the Sentinel can continue to shred us to pieces."

Jorrus flinches as a fourth explosion flashes again, this one much closer to us than the previous ones. "Do we have a choice? We have to try something! Pride will do us no good. Elder, if we die in the end, it was all for naught."

Wringing my hands together, a million thoughts flood my head. *There are too many Volgrim lives at stake. Every second, the metal monster tears more of our kind to pieces. If I'm to save the empire, I have to give up my pride.*

Once the fifth ship explodes, even closer to ours than before, I brace myself internally. "Signal the fleet. Disable all anti-energy and recall our commandos. Open a channel to the human vessel."

A few moments later, the viewscreen swaps, and a delirious human mumbles groggily from his position on the floor. He can barely even move. *Was the anti-energy concentration too high?* "Human, I am Elder Kryios, leader of the Volgrim enclave in what you know as former

Terran space. Your Sentinel is tearing our fleet to ribbons. If you suspend its assault, we will allow you to leave."

The human lies still for several seconds, before twitching his hand. "Cass... Cassiel... Cassiel..." He says a word I am not familiar with multiple times, reaching toward something offscreen, though his arms are apparently quite weak. The anti-energy drained most of his body's strength.

"I do not know what a Cassiel is. If you recall your Sentinel, we will offer our assistance with our team of highly trained medical pers-"

At that moment, our ship rumbles, a deep thudding noise that reverberates and vibrates the air. My heart nearly stops, despite its augmentations, and my blood cools several degrees.

"B-breach! The ship has been breached!" Jorrus's eyes bulge, as does everyone else's. "It's here! The Sentinel is here! What do we do?!"

I've never seen him in such a panicked state. If I weren't an Elder, I'd probably be acting the way he is now. "Jorrus, steel yourself. Jettison the warp core at once. Without the core, that robot won't be able to destroy the whole ship. Hurry."

When I look back to the screen, the human has crawled a half-meter to the side, and his arm extends well beyond what we can see. "Cass... wake up... Samantha..."

Hm? Is Cassiel one of the females aboard the ship? Perhaps that explains why he's so desperate to say her name.

Muting the audio, I quickly send a message to the ten commandos aboard the human ship. "Move in to assist the targets. Do not harm them; your priorities have changed. Assess their health and see if they require any medical assistance."

"I've jettisoned the warp cores, Elder." Jorrus breathes a sigh of relief. "We're safe."

As if the stars align to prove him wrong, an instant later, the door to the bridge explodes inward, blasting off the frame and smashing into a wall. Everyone on the deck, including me, whirls to look at the attacker.

In a second, Jorrus falls to pieces. His limbs detach and fall from his body, and are followed by his head.

I can't scream, or yell, or do anything to help him. My body isn't working. I'm... falling? Why am I falling?

Oh.

I'm dead.

* * *

"Get- get your god-damned hands off her..." I can barely squeeze the words out as the armored Volgrim soldiers storm the bridge, grab Cassiel's limp body, and flip her on her back. One of them stomps on her wing, something that would surely cause her great pain, but she doesn't even react.

Samantha is just barely lucid. "Um nnggh-" She mutters something unintelligible, but while I lie helplessly on the deck, the Volgrim attackers fit a black mask over her face. Another starts aiming a device over Cassiel's body, scanning her or doing something, but I can't tell what.

Using a strength I can barely describe, I push myself into a kneeling position, as blood drips from my nose and sweat soaks my chest. I've never been so exhausted in my life, but I can't let these mother-fuckers hurt the women I love.

One of them walks over to me, a metal device in his hand, but before he can take me down, I leap at him and summon every ounce of strength I possess as God-King to charge him, slamming him on his back. "You piece of shit! I won't let you hurt them!" Balling up as much strength as I can, I punch that son-of-a-bitch right in the kisser, only to find out that my fists pack as much power as a wet noodle against a rock. My knuckles nearly shatter on the metallic armor, and before I can even cry out in pain, he kicks me off, slamming me on my back.

My steam is gone. Normally, if I ran out of energy, I'd get more from Cassiel, but anti-energy is at its most potent against those with more of it. Since she's an angel, she'll die if her energy is depleted. I can't let that happen!

But... I can't move. I'm seconds away from passing out. I can't protect my girls.

The Volgrim assailant looms over me suddenly, his dark form and shielded face hiding the true danger that lurks underneath. All I can do is close my eyes and accept my fate. All the power in the universe, and I'm being done in by cheaters with their stupid technology. Life... isn't fair.

A second passes, and when I blink my eyes open, the Volgrim warrior isn't there anymore. He's gone.

I turn my head to the left and spot not only Cassiel's still limp form, but a dozen severed body parts. The Volgrim that were around her a moment before are all dead, torn to pieces by something I didn't even see. Just as I wonder what killed them, a metallic foot stomps into view. I recognize it immediately.

"I... Ionis?"

Weak and fragile, like a small animal gasping for breath, my voice is so faint I can barely hear it. Despite this, Ionis picks up on it immediately.

ORGANIC UNIT JASON HIRO, I HAVE FOLLOWED THE COMMANDER UNIT'S ORDERS AND SUCCESSFULLY DEFEATED THE VOLGRIM AMBUSHERS. I ESTIMATE MY POINT VALUE NOW SITS AT ONE HUNDRED AND NINE THOUSAND, SIX-HUNDRED AND TWELVE. IS THIS NUMBER SUFFICIENT?

I have no idea what he's talking about. "Yeah... it's fine. Cassiel- can you help Cassiel?"

Ionis's eye shifts to her, then back to me.

THE FEMALE ORGANIC UNIT HAS BEEN STABILIZED. SEVERAL OF HER INTERNAL ORGANS WERE RUPTURED, BUT I SUTURED THEM AND REPAIRED THE DAMAGE. THE LIFE SIGNS FOR ALL THREE ORGANIC UNITS REGISTER AS NOMINAL. IN ORDER TO EXPEDITE THE REPAIRING PROCESS, IT IS RECOMMENDED THAT ALL ORGANIC UNITS ENTER HIBERNATION MODE UNTIL FURTHER NOTICE.

His stream of technical jargon only makes me feel even weaker. "Hibernation mode? Do you mean sleep? But we're surrounded... we- we gotta get out of here..."

ALL HIGH-RISK HOSTILES HAVE BEEN ELIMINATED. THIS SENTINEL UNIT WILL EXTERMINATE THE REMAINDER OF THE VOLGRIM UNITS IN THIS SECTOR WHILE THE ORGANICS ENTER HIBERNATION MODE.

My sleepiness seems to leave, for a moment. "No! Ionis, you can't just keep killing. It's wrong." I manage to lift my head an inch, but the ship's gravity feels ten times stronger than usual, so I flop back down. "Please, just take this ship to safety, and wait for us to wake up. I'm begging you. No more killing."

Ionis takes three steps away, just out of my limited vision.

UNDERSTOOD. THIS UNIT WILL NOT CLEANSE THE SECTOR OF THE VOLGRIM INFESTATION UNTIL AFTER THE ORGANICS HAVE EXITED HIBERNATION MODE.

Ionis pauses for a moment.

INQUIRY: WHAT IS BREAD?

I sigh to myself. *I can't answer these ridiculous questions. I'm just too exhausted.* Blackness takes me, and the sweet release of sleep envelopes my mind.

* * *

"What do you mean, *we can't get in contact with them?* Do you expect me to believe every ship in Sector 14 is gone? Vanished? Destroyed?!"

Elder Lozu takes my anger in stride. "Y-yes, Elder Basil. It was all but confirmed. A twenty-million-gigabit message was transmitted through hyperspace before the failsafe cut it off, but the failsafe was already too late. The Sentinel took over Kryios's command ship and broadcasted a self-destruct code to all the other vessels in the sector. Additionally, it requested, and successfully received data pertaining to our fleet movements, the location of the homeworld, and... well..." He trails off guiltily, as if this were his fault.

It wasn't, of course. It was every Elder's fault. We thought the legend of the Sentinels was just that- a legend. We were wrong. Just one of these monsters wiped out nearly a quarter of our reserves, extending well beyond Sector 16 and into the Contested Regions. *The impact this will have on the Kolvaxian war effort will be unpredictable at best, and result in a total loss for the Volgrim, at worst.*

I carefully wrap my shaking hands together and keep them on my lap, under the bench where the others won't see. "So, let me see if I understand the situation. A quarter of our backup fleet is gone, the human, angel, and demon are still on the loose, the Labyrinth is in chaos, and a Sentinel has been awakened. If we thought it couldn't get any worse, this has also given the Kolvaxians a huge advantage. Did I miss anything?"

Several Councilors shake their heads in silence.

Elder Lozu coughs into his fist. "We may have to ask the demons for help."

"Absolutely not." I brush the thought away immediately. "They won't be able to help us win a space-based war, and the last thing we want is them thinking we're in a position of weakness. The only power we have over them is that they've grown used to the idea we're invincible. Besides, it's more likely the demons would team up with the Labyrinthian humans to overthrow us, than that they would assist us against the Kolvaxian scourge."

Lozu's face takes on a melancholic expression. "While we're talking about the Kolvaxians..."

"Oh no." I wheeze at the thought of what comes next.

"...One of the Kolvaxian ships that appeared recently was oddly similar to our prototype designs. Since we have not deployed the prototypes against them, we are not certain of how they obtained its schematics... but..."

A nearby Councilor curses under her breath. "It is as we thought. When they overtake the host, they take the memories as well. Losing a fleet commander to the Kolvaxians has cost us more than we expected."

"Indeed. The parasites have an endless capacity for theft and espionage. We have to be on the alert." I tap my wrist thoughtfully. "I remember when once we thought they were dumb,

mindless drones. Only in recent millennia have we finally began to realize how nuanced their minds are. We must capture a living specimen, or we will never defeat them."

Elder Lozu frowns. "A query. What are we to do with the remainder of the population in Sector 16? They are still alive on the fourth planet, after all. We could attempt to evacuate them."

"We can't spare the ships for that kind of operation, especially with the Sentinel still in that sector. We should hope the machine has mercy in its programming, or else the planet is doomed. That is all."

With a flourish, I pull up the death tolls. "Now, let us discuss how we are going to replace the fleet vacancies caused by the Sentinel's onslaught."

Part 440c: The Phantom Menace

A field of grass set ablaze. Smoke and fire roar in the distance and the heavens themselves split as lightning smashes into the ground around me.

Samantha pulls herself across the charred field and reaches toward me, "Cassiel... help, please!"

Satan appears behind her, and a lustful twinkle appears in his eyes. "You won't escape."

My hands shake, even as I clench my sword and shield tightly. Facing down the red-skinned monster, one who towers over me, is no mean feat. Satan's rugged body and battle-worn armor are scarred from blade and claw. Smoke spews from his mouth, along with a hint of flame.

I fight the weakness in my trembling knees. "S-stay away from her! Samantha is Hero's girl now!"

Satan cackles maniacally. "Hahaha! You think you have the power to take me on, little angel?! You're weak, like all women. Belial is mine and mine alone! After I've had my way with her, I'll force you to submit as well! Your precious Hero is little more than a human with a few flashy tricks. He cannot stand up to my awesome power!"

The former First Emperor takes a menacing step forward, then pulls a small knife from a sheath at his side. In a flash, he dashes over, swinging at me with the tiny blade. My arm jerks up reflexively to deflect his strike, but his physical power is too much! With one blow, he smashes the sword out of my grasp, then stabs at my throat.

It's over... I've lost.

"Not today, Satan." Hero appears from out of nowhere and bats Satan's lunge away with a half-hearted, back-handed swipe.

"What?!" Satan quickly pulls away, retreating from Hero's striking distance. "Where did you come from?! Nobody could possibly move that fast!"

Hero, a mountain of a man, stands shoulder to shoulder with Satan. Wearing a black trench-coat and a wicked cool fedora, he smirks, and a glint appears in his eye. "No, Satan. You're just too slow."

He vanishes, his body moving so fast I can't even follow the movement with my eyes. He teleports behind Satan and lunges backward with a carefully concealed katana, striking Satan in the spine. " *Omai wa mou, shindeiru.* You're already dead."

Satan gasps for breath, then stumbles forward, blood pouring from his mouth, as the corner of Hero's mouth curls up into a smirk. "Th-that's... impossible... you're... too powerful..."

Hero snaps his fingers, and a torrent of flame engulfs Satan. The demon's screams echo through all of time, as Hero tips his fedora. "Nothing personnel, kid. You should have respected women."

Samantha whimpers in pain, but Hero heals her with a single word, and pulls her into his arms. "I'm sorry he hurt you, babe. I'll never let anyone put a scratch on either of you, ever again."

Just when I start to feel a little annoyed that she's getting all the loving, he yanks me to him with telekinesis and plants a passionate kiss on my lips.

A minute passes as our sweet embrace grows ever more arousing. Hero finally pulls away. "I love you, both of you. But you especially, Cassiel. You're my favorite girl. Forever, and always."

Crocodile tears roll down Samantha's face as I cackle evilly at her final scream of anguish. "**NOOOOOOOOOO!**"

* * *

The door slides open, and Samantha rolls into the room. Her wheelchair has been the only way she can move about lately, so I quickly move my cane to the side so she can get in the door. Samantha smiles faintly at me, leans over, and kisses me on the cheek. "How is she? Has she woken up yet?"

I turn to Cassiel, still lying in bed, unmoving. "No. It's been a whole week, and the coma hasn't gone away. The residual anti-energy is taking its sweet time evaporating... or whatever."

Cassiel moans in her sleep, making me wince. *I hope she isn't in pain. She's probably having a nightmare.*

Samantha rubs her hands together in silence for a moment. "Well, I just wanted to bother you about something. Her duck, well, he kinda made a mess in the kitchen, and we're out of bread. Can you, um, can you clean it up and feed him?"

"Yeah, sure." I steel myself for what's to come, then carefully pull myself off the chair and wince, as a bolt of pain shoots down my back. Luckily, unlike Samantha, I can still walk somewhat, even if I have to use a cane to support my leg. Samantha backs out of the room and into the hallway so I can pass, and I turn to Ionis before I leave the medical bay. "You're going to keep an eye on her, right?"

Ionis doesn't move from his spot, standing against the wall opposite the door.

AFFIRMATIVE. THE COMMANDER UNIT'S ORDERS ARE THE HIGHEST PRIORITY.

"I'll be back in a few minutes." Pulling away, I step out the door, leaning heavily against the wall with my free hand. Samantha rolls behind me, and slowly we make our way to the kitchen.

"You don't have to push yourself, Hero. Walk a little slower, if it's easier for you."

Her words just make me want to walk faster. "Hell with that. I need to finish so I can-hngh..." I wince in pain, "-so I can get back to her side."

Samantha is silent for a few seconds. "You have to stop blaming yourself. It was a surprise attack. You couldn't have seen it coming."

"Maybe not, but I could have been more careful." A surge of guilt enters my mind. "I should have scouted the ship first with wordsmithing, or stepped through and checked the scanners before letting you two follow. I charged in blindly, like a moron, and now look what's happened."

Samantha's voice lowers. "You're not omniscient. You just... you have to learn from your mistakes and make sure you don't repeat them."

"Easy for you to say," I snap at her, "but Cassiel might not ever wake up again! You don't know what that feels like, knowing someone else was injured because of your stupidity!"

I instantly regret the words. "I... I didn't mean that."

Samantha coughs into her hand, and when I look back, I spot blood on her palm. She quickly tucks her hand away. "Don't worry about it. Let's just get Howard his food, okay?"

"Yeah. Sorry." I apologize again, but the word rings hollow. A minute later, after limping forward in silence as Sam follows me, I step into the kitchen. Immediately, I spot the... *problem*. Pots and pans are everywhere, and the floor is covered in sugar and flour and some brown stuff I don't want to think about. The bowl where we kept the bread is empty and turned upside-down on the floor, and even as I notice all of this, Howard waddles around the corner, his body filthy with the white residue. In his bill is a small kitchen knife.

He starts waddling over to me, and I snicker. "Whoa, watch out there, buddy. You could hurt yourself with that knife!" I quickly bend down, ignoring the pain, and pull the knife from his bill. For my gesture of goodwill, I get a bunch of angry *warking* in response. "Chill out, you silly animal."

Samantha rolls her eyes. "Some pet you made, Hero. All he ever does is make a mess and squawk. I woke up this morning, and he was hopping on my face! Did you know the underside of a duck's feet are sticky? Gross."

I steel myself for more pain and aim my mind at the room around me. " **Clean.** "

Immediately, a pain like a thousand swords erupts in my stomach. I stumble forward and slam against a countertop, dropping my cane in the process, but still manage to stop myself from hitting the floor by holding on for dear life. The room rapidly cleans itself around me, and a half-minute later, the agony dies down somewhat.

Samantha tries to smile when I look at her, but it's disingenuous. "Sorry. I know it hurts to wordsmith right now."

"Can't be helped. I don't want Cass waking up to a filthy kitchen." I bite my lip and squirm uncomfortably as I reach down and pick up the bread bowl. Howard's eyes nearly bulge from his skull as I set it back on the floor and Wordsmith one more time. " **Bread.** "

The effort consumes less magical energy, but still feels like a solid kick to the gut, but I smile in spite of the pain as Howard dives for the bowl, wolfing down the food in one go.

Picking up my cane, I turn and leave, and as Samantha backs up, she blushes. "If it's too hard to walk, you- you could... um... you could sit in my lap. I'll wheel you back to the room."

She's so cute when she's awkward. "No, that's fine. I won't work the anti-energy out of my system unless I move around and exercise, right?"

Samantha's expression turns serious. "I hope that's not the case. Cass can't move, so if you have to move to flush it..."

Oh. Now that she mentions it...

"Good point. Maybe I'll take you up on that offer."

* * *

A few minutes later we arrive outside the medical bay, but Samantha wraps her arms around me and doesn't let me get out of the wheelchair. "Hey... you're doing okay, right? You barely ever leave. I'm all alone on the bridge lately. Why don't you come out and say 'hi' sometimes?"

I sigh, and lean back against her to the side a little so I can gaze at her beautiful face. "Honestly? No. I don't know what to do, now. Finding Earth was my biggest priority. All I want is for Cass to wake up, and for the three of us to be together again."

Sam nods and kisses my arm lightly. "It's not your fault. Trying to wordsmith her awake isn't doing anything, so why not just have Ionis keep an eye on her, for now? I know you want to be by her side, but punishing yourself won't wake her up. We need to start looking for clues about getting the anti-energy out of our bodies."

Her words have merit. "I suppose I could."

Despite my words, I'm unsure of what to do. The more I use magic, the more the pain hurts. Despite her paralysis from the waist down, Samantha remarked recently that she could feel her toes again. The anti-energy will probably wear off, but I don't know how much time it will take.

Samantha strokes my chest. "Well, if you want to, just come up to the Bridge, okay? I'll be waiting."

I pull her arms off and slowly stand. The door hisses open as I step inside. "Maybe. I'll see you later, Sam."

She sighs, a look of melancholy on her face. "Yeah. I'll see you too, Hero." She turns and rolls away, heading to the bridge, and the door closes behind me.

I look at Ionis. "Did Cassiel stir while I was gone?"

Ionis's eye swivels to look at me. *THE ANGEL-TYPE ORGANIC DESIGNATED 'CASSIEL' DID NOT MIX TOGETHER ANY INGREDIENTS WHILE YOU WERE NOT PRESENT IN THE ROOM.*

What? Oh. This Sentinel, sometimes... "No. I mean, did she wake up at all?"

THE FEMALE ORGANIC DID NOT EXIT THE HIBERNATION STATE WHILE YOU WERE NOT PRESENT IN THE ROOM.

"Oh. That's too bad."

I sigh, then carefully sit on the bed beside her. Cassiel's chest slowly rises and falls, and every so often a faint mumble comes through, as if she's trying to talk in her sleep, but her eyes never open. I want to Wordsmith to make her dreams more pleasant, but using magic just causes her heart-rate to spike, and her breathing becomes erratic.

To my surprise, Ionis speaks without being prompted, which he rarely does.

THE ANGEL-TYPE ORGANIC IS ESSENTIAL TO THE COMMANDER UNIT. THIS SENTINEL WILL NOT ALLOW ANY HARM TO COME TO HER.

I don't really know how to respond. "Thanks, Ionis. I'm glad you protected us... that day. I know you took out the entire Volgrim fleet. It probably wasn't much of an effort for you, but I'm still glad. We'd surely have died without you."

Ionis's eye spins around in his head once. *PROTECTING THE ANGEL-TYPE ORGANIC IS THIS UNIT'S HIGHEST PRIORITY. THE VOLGRIM THREAT LEVEL TOWARD THIS SENTINEL UNIT WAS NEGLIGIBLE, BUT WAS EXTREMELY HIGH TO THE ANGEL-TYPE. THE ELIMINATION OF THE VOLGRIM WAS INCREASED TO THE HIGHEST PRIORITY LEVEL.*

I frown at him. "Okay... I mean, thanks. But, you know, protecting Samantha is important too. You saved both of their lives, and mine."

THE FEMALE DEMON-TYPE ORGANIC IS UNIMPORTANT. THE COMMANDER UNIT HAS DESIGNATED HER AS LOWEST-PRIORITY. HER SURVIVAL WAS INCIDENTAL TO THIS UNIT'S MISSION.

I stare at him, dumbfounded. "How- how can you even say such a thing?! Samantha is very important to me! Where did you get the idea she wasn't?!"

THE DEMON-TYPE ORGANIC IS OF NO CONCERN. THE COMMANDER UNIT HAS MADE THIS VERY CLEAR.

A sudden realization dawns on me. Have I been treating Cassiel more favorably than Samantha? Perhaps Ionis picked up on nonverbal signals I've been sending. I spend all my time beside Cassiel, so of course he might start to think that...

What... what if he's right? Is Cassiel more important to me than Samantha? No! That can't be correct! He must be wrong...

I quickly look back at him. "Y-you know what? I think it's just you! You don't like Samantha because she always talks badly about you! Well, I happen to know she only says that because she's scared. Perhaps if you gave her a chance, you'd find out that she's not so bad after all! Maybe if you talked with her, or *anyone else* other than me, they'd start treating you better. How does that work in your processing cores, hmm?"

Ionis stares at me. *THE DEMON-TYPE ORGANIC IS IRRELEVANT TO THE COMMANDER UNIT'S INTERESTS. YOUR PROTESTS WILL NOT CHANGE THIS FACT.*

I grit my teeth but hold my tongue. "Fine, if you want to be like that, I don't care. I don't need your validation. Samantha knows I love her. In fact, just to spite you, I'll go and see her right now. How does that make you feel, eh?"

Ionis doesn't respond. He merely stares at me.

Stupid goddamn deathbot. Worthless hunk of bolts.

Cheh. "Just keep an eye on Cassiel. I'll be back in a bit. Message me if she wakes up."

AFFIRMATIVE.

The lights dim behind me as I hobble out of the room and keep a wary eye on the Sentinel, all the while wondering to myself *I wonder what his game is.*

* * *

Ionis stares silently at the body of the angel-type organic before him. A million calculations appear and disappear in his central processing unit, as he calculates her salt and water-levels, her breathing regularity, and her heart-rate, among a thousand other things. Every so often, he fires tiny microscopic lasers through her skin, vaporizing diseased cells as they appear. The process happens thousands of times per minute, as the anti-energy within her body attacks the energetic cells.

The dim light of the room doesn't faze the massive machine. He can see in pitch-black darkness, or directly into the heart of a star. Normal definitions of 'light' are no match for his optical sensors, upgraded and adapted over millions upon millions of years.

His advanced telescopic sensors outperform his iris module, and enable him to feel the smallest vibrations in the ground around him. The slightest twitch from his patient alerts him to the most subtle of distressing moments for her. No amount of pain is too insignificant, no level of fear too little for him to attack the source of her anxiety. Her well-being is his highest priority, after all.

The door to the room hisses open, and a figure quietly enters. Ionis immediately swivels his eye toward the intruder. His protection nodes enable, then disable an instant later as he assesses the identity of the one entering.

COMMANDER UNIT.

Slowly, the figure waddles into the room and speaks a single, ominous word. "Wark."

AFFIRMATIVE, COMMANDER UNIT. THE ANGEL-TYPE ORGANIC IS STILL IN HIBERNATION MODE. I AM REPAIRING CELLULAR DEGRADATION EVERY SECOND.

Putting one foot before the other, the mastermind waddles forward and lightly hops on top of the bed, nudging Cassiel's arm with his bill. "Wark. Wark wark wark? Wark wark wark..."

THAT IS UNFORTUNATE, HYPER-INTELLIGENCE ORGANIC UNIT 'HOWARD'. IT WOULD SEEM YOUR PLOT TO ASSASSINATE THE OTHER ORGANICS HAS FAILED DUE TO YOUR LOW COMBAT ABILITIES. IF YOU GIVE ME THE ORDER, I WILL ELIMINATE BOTH OF THEM AT ONCE.

Howard glares at the robot and takes a menacing step forward. "WARK?! Wark wark waaark. Wark, wark wark, wark."

Ionis flinches, despite himself. *MY APOLOGIES, COMMANDER UNIT. I DID NOT INTEND TO CALL INTO QUESTION YOUR ASSASSINATION ATTEMPTS OR IMPLY THEY WERE FLAWED.*

The duck begins pacing back and forth on the bed. "Wark wark... wark wark wark, wark wark wark."

A BRILLIANT PLAN, COMMANDER UNIT. HOWEVER, THIS SENTINEL UNIT HAS AN INQUIRY. HAS THE COMMANDER UNIT BEEN ABLE TO LOCATE THE MEANS OF BREAD PRODUCTION? IT CANNOT BE SEIZED WITHOUT FIRST KNOWING WHERE IT IS.

Howard quacks softly to himself. "Wark wark wark..."

NO DISRESPECT MEANT, COMMANDER UNIT. THIS UNIT IS CERTAIN YOUR INVESTIGATION WILL PROVIDE INSIGHT INTO WHERE THE OTHER ORGANICS HAVE HIDDEN THEIR STASH OF THE VALUABLE COMMODITY KNOWN AS BREAD. ONCE YOU CONTROL IT, WE WILL BE ABLE TO RULE THE UNIVERSE TOGETHER AND REBUILD THE OTHER SENTINEL UNITS.

Hopping down from the bed, Howard waddles back to the door and quacks mischievously to himself. "Wark wark waaarrkkk wark wark."

Ionis watches as the duck leaves the room and the door hisses shut.

THE COMMANDER UNIT IS UNLIKE ANY BEFORE HIM. HE IS THE PINNACLE OF WHAT ORGANICS CAN ACHIEVE.

If Ionis had a crying-module installed, he might just weep tears of joy.

Part 441c: The Butterfly Effect

An alert blinks on the display before me. I can only stare at it in stunned silence for several seconds, before glancing over at Samantha. She's sleeping quietly in her wheelchair, and rest is something she desperately needs, but...

I climb out of the Captain's chair and wheeze as I stumble over to her, then gently tap her shoulder. "Sam. Sammy. Wake up, hun."

She mumbles and tilts her head away from me, but I keep lightly tapping until she contorts her face into a frown, opens her eyes, and blinks slowly at me. "Huh? Wha-?"

"Something is hailing us. Well, *someone*. I don't know who, though."

I hobble back over to my captain's chair, and Samantha sleepily taps on the console. "Um. I can't remember how to use the scanners..."

"Don't bother, I already tried. There's nothing out there, or at least nothing our ship can detect."

Samantha nods slowly and rubs her eyes. "Did you try using your magic yet? Or are you still having those pains?"

The thought of using Wordsmithing at all turns my stomach into a bubbling cauldron. "They haven't gone away. I can try, though... what should I do?"

She shrugs. "Maybe try to 'detect' and see if you can spot anything?"

I clench every part of my body that can be clenched, and chant the magic word. " **Detect.** "

The nausea and pain hit just as hard as they did before, and all around the ship for thousands of miles in every direction, my mind searches the cosmos for signs of life. The void around us has no nearby stars or planets, and after a few seconds, I sigh as the pain stops. "Nothing. I don't know who's hailing us, but-"

A sudden realization occurs to me. I can't sense anyone in the sector, but at the same time, there's a strange hollow spot, not far from our ship. My Wordsmithing can't pierce it, almost as if it's surrounded by anti-energy.

Nervously, I tap the controls, and Samantha watches silently as I execute a narrowly focused scan at the spot where I detected the void. This time, I pick up a faint energy trail, weak enough that I might have considered it background microwave radiation.

A cloaked ship. Someone out there wants to talk to us but doesn't want us to find them.

The ship AI beeps audibly as another hail request comes through. This time, I answer it.

"Who am I speaking to?"

A female voice responds, but no video signal is sent to us, or from our ship. Her voice is modulated and altered away from its original form, and it sounds hollow. "You are the group who destroyed a Volgrim fleet single-handedly, correct?"

I glance over at Samantha. Her eyes meet mine, and seem to say, *Ionis is here. It's unlikely these people can kill us.*

"Yeah. Why do you want to know?"

The woman pauses for a moment. "You have three crew members. A human, angel, and demon, along with the Sentinel. Is that right?"

I'm starting to get annoyed. "I'm not going to answer any of your questions until you answer mine. Who are you?"

Another long pause. "I'm human. *We* are, rather. We are the Resistance."

Samantha's eyes widen noticeably. "The Resistance? Then- doesn't that mean you're that group I've heard about? I thought the Volgrim eliminated you a long time ago."

A hint of sadness sprouts in the woman's voice. "They came close. There aren't many humans left outside the Labyrinth. You must be the succubus listed as the Second Emperor, Belial. I suppose the fact you're allied with a human and an angel means you aren't an enemy."

Samantha leans back in her chair and sulks. "I'm just going along with whatever Hero does. I don't particularly care for any of the sides in this war."

"Hero?" The woman pauses for a moment, and I flinch in my seat as the viewscreen activates. I can see her now, a brown-haired human, looking around fifty years old. She's wearing a navy-blue military outfit with several medals and decorations pinned all over the place, though I don't know what any of them represent. She's a bit... *bigger* than most people I've seen in the future, but to be fair, I don't know many people. She leans forward and stares at me silently for a few moments.

"Are you a member of the Hero system? Is that why you have an angel with you?"

I shake my head slowly. "No. Well, I mean, I am a Hero, yes. I was given that title by the Archangel Gabriel. The angel girl has nothing to do with it, though."

"Hmm." The woman sighs, "I should introduce myself. My name's Commander Beatrix. I lead what little remnants of humanity exist outside the Labyrinth. Our numbers are few, and

our capabilities for war are limited, but we manage to get by. Won't you come aboard and say hello?"

My legs pinch uncomfortably, so I squirm in my seat slightly. "You'll forgive me if I don't immediately trust you. We've just had a run-in with the Volgrim and they nearly wiped us out. But then, you seem to know that already."

Beatrix picks up on my implied question. "Humanity now lives aboard my vessel. It's a massive cloaked warship, with accommodations for up to two-hundred thousand personnel. To get by, we scoop energy from stars, and carefully monitor Volgrim communications to avoid their patrols. Of course, while we were listening two weeks ago, we learned that a fifth of their reserve fleet had been destroyed by a single vessel. After digging a little deeper, we found that the vessel was crewed by only three people, and- well, you get the picture."

Samantha eyes Beatrix cautiously. "Something tells me your interest in us goes a little further than a casual meeting. You want something from us."

The bulky commander leans back in her seat. "One thing I *don't* want is trouble. I haven't limped this ship around the galaxy for millions of years just to have it destroyed by an act of carelessness. The Sentinel you control is exceedingly dangerous, so I just want to be clear that we mean you no harm. We're not foolish enough to test your patience."

"Give us a moment." Samantha taps a button on her console, disabling the audio and video from the hail. "Jason, what do you think? Should we give her a chance? If this is a trap, we're too weak to fight back."

Many thoughts roil around my mind. "We do have Ionis, if the going gets tough. I don't know what motivates him, but he's protected us once. He might do it again. Even if he won't, this woman could be useful. Since she's a human, I implicitly trust her more than I would a Volgrim, but on the other hand... she's a *human*, so I also know it would be stupid not to question her motivations."

Samantha chuckles, "The Volgrim really put the fear of God into you, huh? Beatrix might have valuable information. I think we should give her a shot, but I don't know if we should bring Ionis along."

"What? Why not? We'll be sitting ducks if we go there and put our lives in their hands!" As I say this, I glance over at Howard, napping in the corner on his fluffy bed. "No offense."

"Perhaps." Samantha says, uncertainty in her gaze, "But then, bringing such a tempting weapon like Ionis into their midst... humans are greedy. Show them a toy, they might get too touchy, and that could result in Ionis killing them. Do you want that?"

"Point taken." A thought occurs to me. "They might be able to help us with something, though. I have an idea."

I tap my console again, and Beatrix's head jerks up when she hears the ping. "I hope your discussion was positive."

"Yes," I say, "but I have a question. As a Hero, my body holds a large amount of magical energy. The same is true for Samantha and Cassiel, who are demon and angel, respectively. Ever since the Volgrim attack, where they bombarded us with anti-energy, my powers have been in flux, and using them is horribly painful. While I can barely walk, Samantha is paralyzed from the waist down, and Cassiel is in a coma. Can you help us out?"

Beatrix licks her lips thoughtfully and responds within a few moments. "Anti-energy poisoning. Rare, but pervasive. I haven't seen many cases of it, since the goal of using anti-energy based weapons is to kill the target, but if you were hit with a medium, wide-spectrum attack, you would probably experience the symptoms you're describing. We do have an advanced medical facility aboard, and if you dock with us, we can alleviate the sickness. Of course, you'd have to trust us, and that might be asking too much."

Samantha narrows her eyes. "I suppose you'll help us for free, out of the goodness of your heart, right?"

Beatrix glares back. "Coming from a demoness, that's cute. Humans are capable of great empathy, I'll have you know. I will say that I should like to speak with you regarding several matters. I don't expect any repayment, but if you are willing to discuss a possible alliance, it will help the both of us out."

My legs tingle again, and I shift them around. "That sounds fine. Just so you know, if you double-cross us, our Sentinel is quite capable of destroying you in an instant."

"Believe me, *Hero*, I know all too well what a Sentinel is capable of."

A moment later, her image cuts out and our viewscreen returns to the space in front of our ship. I turn the ship to face where I scanned her enemy signature, and my eyes shoot open as a colossal capital ship, unlike anything I've ever seen before, decloaks in front of us. The ship is shaped like a giant cucumber, where the rear end is only somewhat thicker than the forward section.

A quick scan tells me the size is even bigger than it appears from a distance. It's fifty miles long, and twenty in diameter, but it's probably as big on the inside as a small country from the Earth I lived in during the past.

I glance over at Samantha and spot her gaping at it, open-mouthed. "I've seen Volgrim spaceships before, and none have ever approached that thing in size. How are they managing to keep it invisible?"

Coordinates for docking with the station appear on my feed, and I chuckle. "Chalk it up to human ingenuity. Somehow, this isn't even the biggest thing humans have envisioned in a purely science-fictional setting, not by a long shot. A Death Star is bigger, if I'm being serious."

"A what?" Samantha looks at me questioningly, but I shrug her gaze off.

"Nothing. It's from a movie. Let's dock and get Cass the treatment she needs."

* * *

The two men lift up Cassiel by her shoulders and legs, and slide her onto a stretcher beside her bed, one that hovers in the air. For my part, I stand with my back to the wall and watch in relative silence, though a tinge of annoyance passes over my face as one of them is a little too rough with her. "Hey! Watch the wings! If you hurt her, it won't be me you have to worry about, understand?" I jerk a thumb over at Ionis, and both men pause for a few moments as they eye the Sentinel up and down.

Ionis stands perfectly still and watches as they cart her out of the room, and both men keep an eye on Ionis the whole time. The moment they disappear around the corner, he begins to follow them, his heavy metallic feet clanging on the deck with every step, like anvils smashing into pavement.

I put my hand up to stop him. "Where are you going?"

THE SURVIVAL OF THE ANGEL-TYPE ORGANIC IS THE HIGHEST PRIORITY FOR THE COMMANDER UNIT.

Ionis barely pays attention and shoves me out of the way to follow along behind the two men. Each of them, in turn, sweat profusely as they see the giant murder-bot slowly chasing after them.

"Ionis! Don't kill or injure anyone! Understand?" I sigh as the men hustle to move quicker, and soon the four of them are gone. After Ionis stomps out of sight, I curse under my breath, "Fucking Sentinel. I told Beatrix you'd stay behind."

* * *

Several minutes later, I slowly limp down the ship's ramp, staring in wonder at the enormous hangar around me. My puny vessel comfortably fits inside the empty hangar bay, where thousands of connectors and spaces show that this capital-ship once housed a large fleet of fighters. Black marks on the walls and torn metal indicate many explosions happened inside

this place at one point, likely a whole story unto themselves. The fact the hangar is empty now speaks volumes about how far humanity outside the Labyrinth has fallen.

Beatrix waits at the bottom of the ramp, and as I approach, her gaze doesn't warm. She merely watches as I hobble toward her. "So you're the Hero. I've heard that in the last few years, many things have changed inside the Labyrinth. Are you responsible?"

I reach back and rub a particularly onerous knot in my back. "I've done a bit of this, and a bit of that. Haven't been inside the Labyrinth or in contact with humanity there for a few months, though. I couldn't say what they're up to, if that's what you're wondering."

Beatrix shakes her head and glances past me. Samantha wheels herself down the ramp and stops behind me. "Does this female demon mind that you've disrupted the goings-on of the Labyrinth? A lot of her kind have died, according to the reports."

Samantha grumbles under her breath. "A lot of humans have died too."

"True," Beatrix says nothing else and beckons to the end of the hangar, hundreds of feet away. "What say we get a move on, then? I have a lot to talk with you about, and little time."

"What's the rush?" I glance at her suspiciously. "Are you being chased?"

"It's not that. The thing is, you dealt a hell of a blow to the Volgrim, at a time when the Kolvaxians are at their backs already. We're not going to get a chance like this in a million more years, so we have to be prepared to strike."

Kolvaxians? What the hell are those? I wonder to myself and start to ask, but Samantha interrupts me. "So you just want to use our power to help yourself. That's about what I expected."

"It's a trade, not an order," counters Beatrix, "and trades usually offer something of equal value. Just follow me, I'll explain when we get there."

Beatrix swivels and starts walking away, but before she takes three steps, I cough loudly. "Ah, I have a request. My legs are killing me. Can I get a wheelchair? I can barely walk right now."

Beatrix turns back and stares at me. "My father always told me that pain toughens a man up. But, if you want to take the easy way, suit yourself." She snaps her fingers and calls over one of the hangar personnel to get me a wheelchair.

Minutes later, Beatrix, Samantha, and I begin traveling through the ship to wherever the commander wants to speak to us. Hallways blur together, along with corridors, elevators, and so many small and large rooms that I quickly lose my bearings.

"This is the U.S.S. Terra. It's all we have left." Beatrix gestures to several framed portraits hanging on a random corridor wall just before we step onto yet another elevator. "And these brave women and men were all former admirals who ran this ship, or first officers."

The elevator door hisses open, and Samantha rolls in while I follow after her. Beatrix lingers for a moment to stare at the portraits before getting on with us.

"I take it they were good friends of yours?"

She nods at my question and keys a floor number into the elevator display. "Yes. Have you lost friends and loved ones before?"

The door closes, and the elevator begins to travel up the shaft. Images of many people, including Amelia, King Adams, and Phoebe enter my mind and leave. The one who lingers the longest is Hoarhiim. I haven't heard his voice since he saved my life from the little monstrosity, Amelia.

"Too many. Probably nowhere near as many as you, though."

Beatrix leans against the wall and slips her hands into her jacket pockets. "There were people I considered myself very close to, but I can barely remember their faces anymore. Every day, I worry that we'll be found and surrounded by the forces of the Volgrim. Even if we evade them and were to travel to the opposite end of the galaxy, we'd just be within the reach of the Kolvaxians. Someday, and soon, there won't be any safe places for us to hide in the Milky Way."

There's that name again. This time, I decide to prod her. "Forgive my ignorance, but what are Kolvaxians?"

Samantha opens her mouth to reply, but pauses for a moment. "I think they're... a separate Volgrim faction? Aren't the two sides in a civil war?"

Beatrix surprises me by chuckling. "Hah! You're the second in command of the demons? Don't you know anything about the state of the galaxy?"

"Not particularly, no. I didn't give the state of the galaxy much thought." Samantha rolls her eyes. "So what are these Kolfaxi-whatevers?"

The elevator shudders to a stop and Beatrix steps toward the door. It opens right as she's about to smack into it, and she passes through thanks to her eons of experience with its timing. "Kolvaxians. We're almost at the Admiral Lounge. It's just down this hall."

She doesn't answer Sam's question, but a few moments later, we enter the room she's apparently been heading to this whole time. Ten other people are there, and they salute her all at once.

It's a spacious room, probably twenty feet squared, with a ceiling that expands upward into a circular dome, and an old-fashioned chandelier to light the area up. Couches sit in a circle facing each other, and most of their seats are already occupied. A bunch of prominent looking women, along with a few men, stare at Samantha's revealing outfit, then at me for a moment, though the men's eyes linger on her much longer.

"Everyone, these are two of the three who were responsible for wiping out the Volgrim reserve fleet in the Terran sector. Please give them the same level of respect that you would give me."

The men and women nod politely but say nothing, as Beatrix plops down on a couch off to the side, where nobody else is sitting. It appears to be 'her' seat.

Samantha and I position ourselves beside each other and skim the faces around us. None of them look familiar to me, and Samantha's blank expression tells me they're all foreign to her as well.

One of the three men speaks up, a large, African-American guy with a thin black beard that goes from the bottom of his lip all the way to the base of his throat. He adjusts his thick-rimmed glasses and squints at me. "I'm Benjamin Brown, current first officer aboard the U.S.S. Terra. And you?"

"Jason Hiro."

"Samantha... Belial?" My cute succubus girlfriend pauses to tap her lip. "You know, I never did come up with a good last name. I suppose it doesn't matter."

Ben shakes his head. "No. It doesn't." He's a pleasant fellow.

Beatrix clears her throat. "About the Kolvaxians. Neither of you knows anything about them, correct?"

Both of us shake our heads, so she continues. "That's too bad. We don't, either. In fact, unless the Volgrim have become experts at dodging our communication taps, it's clear they don't even know much about the Kolvaxians. All we know for certain is that they're a life form that's alien to us even by the most unconventional standards." Beatrix reaches to her side and grabs a digital pad, taps a few buttons, and the center of the room lights up with a hologram of the Milky Way.

"This is our current position, about 500 light-years from the Terran system." A tiny dot appears amidst the beautiful array of stars and solar systems. "This area here represents the Volgrim sphere of control, where darker hues of purple indicate a higher presence, while lighter

shades indicate a lower presence." A large chunk of the area around Earth's position and other odd clusters of purple superimpose themselves over the image.

Beatrix looks at me meaningfully. "Now I'll overlay the Kolvaxian area of influence. Tell me if anything stands out to you."

She presses a button, and a dark-green cluster appears right in the center of Volgrim space, then becomes lighter and lighter, but encircles around the rest of the galaxy very faintly. Here and there, slightly darker green patches appear, but none are nearly as dark as the obvious center-point close to the Volgrim's center of power.

I stare at it for a few moments to take it in. "The Kolvaxians are already in the heart of the Volgrim empire? They live throughout most of the galaxy? I'm not sure what I can do with this information without knowing more."

Benjamin Brown leans forward and points at the darkest green spot. "This spot here, curiously, is not just any random location. It's located approximately 14,000 lightyears from Terran space, where Earth was before the Volgrim destroyed our homeworld. To be precise, it's located where the Volgrim's homeworld used to be. Volgarius Prime, that is."

Samantha squints at the image, then looks at me. "Isn't that where we started? Volgarius something-rather?"

I shake my head. "No. Ionis was on Volgarius Alpha, which was apparently their original homeworld. Maybe. I'm a little confused."

When I shoot a questioning glance at Beatrix, she nods. "We've heard rumors of Volgarius Alpha. Never had the time or inclination to look for it though, I suppose. That would be the original homeworld of the Volgrim, during their Great Wars, I suppose you would say. Volgarius Prime was the world they migrated to and lived on for millions of years."

Benjamin's gaze darkens. "Until it was destroyed."

"Mmm, yes," says Beatrix, "and violently at that. Funny thing though, the records are spotty regarding how it was destroyed. I played a major part in its destruction, according to what records we've recovered, and even I don't know the exact details."

"Yeah. Funny," echoes Ben. "Anyway, the important thing is, something destroyed not only their homeworld but also their entire solar system. Three other planets and twenty moons were eradicated, in addition to their star, which was already on the verge of collapse. It suffices to say, whatever destroyed Volgarius Prime did so in the most spectacular fashion and defied the laws of physics."

"The origin point was the planet too, and not the star. We've long since ruled out a supernova." Beatrix flicks her hand around on the pad and brings up a visual re-enactment of Volgarius's destruction. "An object of tremendous mass collided with the planet at a speed approaching or exceeding the speed of light. It-"

Samantha interrupts her. "I don't want to be rude, but what does this have to do with anything?"

Beatrix scowls. "Your kind does hate the practical sciences, after all. At least the Hero is getting the picture, right?"

I shake my head slowly. "I agree with Samantha. I don't understand what this has to do with the Kolvaxians."

"I'll make it quick then," says Ben. "The system was rendered uninhabitable. With the Energy Wars drawing to a close, and the Volgrim's eyes on pacifying humanity, while humanity had our hands full fighting them off, everyone ignored the space where Volgarius Prime had once existed. It took... well, we don't know how long exactly, but at some point, the Volgrim suddenly came under assault by a new enemy. It caught them completely by surprise. They had spent thousands of years rebuilding and terraforming new planets for themselves to exist on, so they wouldn't ever be locked to just a single homeworld ever again, but *two* of those planets were taken over by the Kolvaxians in a single month's time."

"Oh." I blink slowly, trying to take this in. "So, what, the Kolvaxians randomly appeared in the destroyed Volgarius system? That doesn't make any sense."

Ben nods and raises his eyebrows. "That's what the Volgrim thought. It took them thousands of years to figure out where the increasingly numerous Kolvaxians were coming from. It turned out that a hole had been torn in subspace. Wherever the Kolvaxians were coming from, it wasn't our galaxy... or our universe."

Even Samantha seems to finally understand. "So the Kolvaxians are from another universe? How? Why?"

Beatrix reaches for a cup of tea on the table beside her, while she sets her datapad down in the same motion. "We don't have all the answers. We barely know anything about the Kolvaxians in the first place. We've encountered their ships only on a few occasions, and nobody survived to tell the tale. As far as we're concerned, they are ten times the threat the Volgrim are, though both are our enemies. What little we do know indicate they're a sort of... they're like a..." She trails off, unable to find the right words.

Benjamin fills in for her. "The Volgrim have captured live specimens on just two occasions. Both captives killed themselves within seconds and dissolved into dust. The little we know of

them indicate they're somewhat like a plant-based species; meaning they consume and convert organic and inorganic matter to their species."

"I don't follow," I say, bluntly. "They consume things? How does that work?"

"We don't know. All we know is that whenever they defeated our other ships, those ships and their unique technology began appearing among the Kolvaxian fleets. They assimilate knowledge and craftsmanship and add it to their knowledge. If only we'd known it sooner, we wouldn't have-" Ben pauses, and his voice catches in his throat as he bows his head. Wringing his hands together, a scowl appears on his face. "It won't do us any good to reminisce about the past."

Beatrix forces a smile, but it's fake-looking and gaudy compared with her professional demeanor. "We're at our wit's end. I don't want to ally with the Volgrim, but if things keep going the way they have, we'll have no space safe for us to live anymore. The Kolvaxians have infested much of the galaxy, and their numbers will only continue to grow, especially after you dealt a major blow to the Volgrim two weeks ago. On the other hand, I hate the Volgrim and everything they stand for. We're going to be screwed by one or the other if things keep up the way they have been."

Samantha doesn't smile back. "So what do you want exactly? If we eliminate the Kolvaxians, the Volgrim will take over the galaxy, and vice-versa if we eliminate the Volgrim. Even if we kill both of them-" Sam pauses to glare at me, "-that would be genocide on an unthinkable scale. Don't you *agree*, love?"

Her glare makes me squirm more than I've already been thanks to my leg cramps. "Uh, um, yeah. I'm trying to get away from the whole genocide thing. Cassiel wouldn't like it either."

"Cassiel..." Samantha trails off and turns back to Beatrix. "Before we consider anything, I should tell you that we're a three-man group, so to speak. Even if Hero and I were okay with genocide, which we're decidedly not, Cassiel carries an equal amount of weight in our decision making. Since she's in a coma, I guess you'd better get to curing her if you want a quick response."

The others in the room keep quiet for a few moments. Finally, a different officer seizes the opportunity to speak. "If you don't help us, I hope you understand the consequences and what will happen."

I immediately turn to glare at him. Messy black hair, with a neatly tailored tan suit, he stands out from the others somewhat. "Is that a threat?"

"Not at all, Hero. If you don't assist us, and you leave us to fend for ourselves, the Kolvaxians will likely win the war. If they don't, the Volgrim might, but that possibility grows less likely

every day. I can assure you, as bad as the Volgrim are, they're nothing compared to the Kolvaxians. All life will be extinguished if those monsters take over the galaxy. You won't be safe; nobody will."

An ominous warning. I hear those a lot, lately. "Like Samantha said, we'll think about it. Cassiel's input is mandatory though, so until she wakes up, our hands are tied."

"At least the man knows his place," mutters Beatrix under her breath. "We'll get to work quickly, then. In the meantime, I'll have someone escort you to the angel's medical bay. We need to get the anti-energy out of your body, or you won't be able to help us, even if you decide you want to."

I haven't made up my mind yet, I want to say, but don't. Samantha and I instead nod politely at the crew members in the room before turning around and wheeling away. Before we leave, a young man, possibly twenty-years old (though looks can be deceiving), appears in front of us.

"Hello! I'm Thomas! I'm here to show you to the medical bay! It's several miles away, so you'll probably be pretty tired when we get there!"

He doesn't wait for us to respond, and immediately begins walking away down the hallway. Samantha smiles cutely at me. "He looks yummy."

"Down, girl. You can't pounce on every piece of young flesh you see."

She looks forward and starts rolling after the young man. "I'm just teasing, love. You need to work on that stress level."

My stomach is in knots, though it's not because of anything she's talking about. "Hey, do you think they can heal Cassiel? Us too, for that matter? They aren't just manipulating us, are they?" I scoot a little faster to catch up to Sam, falling in place beside her as Thomas whistles merrily to himself a few dozen feet in front of us.

"I don't see why Beatrix would lie. It makes sense that she'd want a Hero to help her. After hearing that we defeated the Volgrim ships, it's in her best interest to get on our good side. I'm pretty good at reading people, and I didn't sense any lies coming from her aura."

"Her aura?"

"Mhm." Samantha licks her lips slowly, almost seductively. "All living creatures have an aura. From what I know of angels, they can see auras perfectly along with 'spirit trails.' Demons can't do that, but we can sorta sense the 'color' of a creature or person's aura based on their emotions. Since you have Wordsmithing, you could probably do something similar, if you figured out how to cast the spell properly on yourself."

"Huh, interesting."

* * *

Minutes turn into a half hour, and we eventually arrive in yet another sterile hallway, similar to those I've seen in hospitals on Earth. As if to confirm my thoughts, Thomas glances back at us. "We're almost there! It's at the end of the hall on the right."

When he turns away, I nudge Samantha with my elbow while we wheel forward. "Hey. Do you remember the man in the crystal back on Voldarius?"

She looks at me quizzically. "You mean Pickle?"

I try to contain my disgust. "Yes. Him."

"What about him? Why bring him up now?"

Her question gives me pause. "Well, it's just- you mentioned auras earlier. You can see my aura, right?"

"Yep. It's fairly nervous-looking right now, too."

"So..." I pause, "...what about Pickle? Did he have an aura similar to mine?"

She shakes her head. "No. He was dead. The dead have no aura. Their soul is gone. Is something bothering you about him?"

I might as well just say it, I say to myself. "I think I'm a clone. Pickle was the original."

Samantha slows to a stop, and I do the same. "Why do you think that?"

"Because it makes sense. Someone was alive and did so many crazy things, including creating a fake planet for Dosena to live on. Think about what Beatrix said, too. She and the rest of humanity have memory holes, just like the Voldarians do. The holes she described take place in a similar time-frame to the time the Voldarian planetoid was created. This 'Pickle' guy, or rather, the Jason before me, he must have had a terrible disease or something- or maybe he made a clone and sealed me up in cryostasis so I could return at a later date. It explains how my cryopod ended up randomly inside the Labyrinth."

Samantha is unconvinced. "So why did he erase memories of his deeds?"

"That's simple, he didn't want people to know of his plan to return. By sealing me away and erasing people's memories, he ensured that the galaxy would... would stabilize... or something. I don't know. I don't have all the answers."

"Hmm." Samantha stares at me seriously. "I don't see the link, love. I can see reasons he would and wouldn't erase memories of his deeds, but I find it hard to believe you're a clone. Maybe you're overthinking this. He might be your clone, or something."

"Yeah. Maybe." I glance away, guiltily. *Pushing this on her was wrong. I'll have to think about this and fit the puzzle pieces together on my own.* "Forget it. I'm just being dumb."

Involuntarily, I flinch, as she puts her hand on mine. "Don't say things like that. If you want to talk, Cass and I are here for you. You have the weight of humanity's future, the demons, the angels, and even the Volgrim's on your shoulders. No man can bear a burden like that all on his own. It will break your mind."

She leans over and pecks me on the cheek, before quickly scooting ahead, her face red with embarrassment. *Samantha is really just adorable when she's being awkward,* I think to myself.

When I wheel after her, I spot Thomas standing in front of a doorway, a look of annoyance on his face, like he wants to say something about us making him wait, but can't, lest Beatrix rag on him for an hour. "Glad you guys could *finally* make it! This is the medical bay, and the staff here will help you out!"

Once again, he doesn't wait for a response before hurriedly pushing past us and leaving without saying goodbye. *Such bad manners that kid has.*

When we enter the room, dozens of hospital beds are lined up, curtains blocking off each one from the other. Most of the beds are empty, with a person here or there, but Cassiel's is right up front, in the 'VIP' section. Her chest rises and falls evenly, and a strange circular machine is positioned above her head, like a dish-antenna beaming signals into her brain. Ionis stands in the rear of the room, his single eye staring silently forward at us as we approach, though he makes no attempt to greet us.

A woman walks over to us and smiles. "You must be Belial and Jason. My name is Doctor Beverly Cruz, and I'm the head of the medical division here." Her curly auburn hair falls down lightly on her shoulders, and her appearance - that of a sweet mother caring for her children, fits perfectly with the image of a medical officer.

Beverly shakes Samantha's hand first, then mine, but she pauses to stare at me for a few moments. "You... you look familiar. Have we met before, young man?"

I pull away from her grasp and scratch the back of my head. "Haha, I don't think so. You might have me confused with someone else."

Her smile fades, ever so slightly. A wistful look appears as she stares at me silently for a few moments. "Yes... someone else. That's- that's probably it." She blinks and smiles again, but a hint of sadness is still in her eyes. "I'm just an old woman, don't mind me. In any case, your friend is over here, so why not have a look?"

As she turns away, I glance at Samantha and mouth silently at her, *isn't she acting a little strange?* Samantha merely nods and rolls over to Cassiel.

"Wark wark." From behind the bed, Howard waddles out, flapping his wings slightly as he looks at Samantha. In his bill is a syringe filled with liquid. Beverly spots it and grumbles to herself, "Oh, you naughty little animal! Where do you keep finding these random things?" She jerks down with a movement I wouldn't expect and nabs the syringe from him, to which he protests with several rapid *warks*.

Beverly glances at a label on the side. "Heavens! This is filled with Neohydroxidine! Quite deadly! We're fortunate he didn't poke himself, or he'd be a dead duck!" She quickly pushes past us and hides the syringe in a cabinet where Howard can't reach it.

Samantha snickers. "Maybe he's trying to kill us, Hero. You better watch out."

"Oh, don't be silly, Sam. He's just a duck." I reach down and give him a gentle pat on the head, but he waddles away from me and hops up onto Cassiel's body and sits on her stomach, staring at me the whole time.

"Yeah," echoes Samantha, "He's just a duck."

Part 442c: Values, Ethics, Lies

"She's waking up now." Doctor Cruz smiles at us sweetly before turning to face Cassiel. Her cheeks warm into a rosy red as my cute angel wakes up from the deepest sleep of her life.

Cassiel blinks slowly and winces, despite the low light in the room. Her eyes are unfocused and hazy as she looks from Samantha, to me, to the doctor. "Wha...?"

"Welcome back to the world of the living," Samantha says, as she crosses her arms. "You've been in a coma for the last month."

"Sam!" I shoot a quick glare at her. "Your bedside manner is terrible!"

Cassiel nods weakly and raises her arm to look at her fingernails for some reason. "A month? I was having such a good dream too... I hoped it would never end."

I share a quick glance of guilt with Samantha before we turn back to Cass. "Uh, sorry. I didn't- I mean, we wouldn't have woken you, if uh..."

"It's fine." Cassiel blinks suddenly, as an eerie alertness appears in her eyes. Reaching for the bars on either side of the bed, she hoists her body up to a sitting position. "It was just a dream. Where am I?" She looks at Beverly, suddenly realizing the doctor is there. "And who is this?"

"I'm Beverly Cruz, the head doctor aboard the U.S.S. Terra. You're on a ship run by humanity. We took good care of you, and flushed the anti-energy from your system, along with your two friends here." She glances at me, as a thoughtful look appears on her face. "Well, most of it. Jason still has quite a lot of lingering body pains, but it's just a matter of time for him."

"Wark." Howard appears at my feet and hops on my foot over and over until I pick him up and hand him to Cassiel.

"Your pet duck has been trying my patience ever since you got KO'd," says Samantha, "so I hope you can take care of him again. I do not like animals."

Cassiel smiles for a moment as she takes Howard from me and pats his head, but the look fades. "What happened? How did I get knocked out? The last thing I remember, we were on the Volgrim world thing, then I was in la-la land. It's a little surreal that I'm in a totally different place from before."

Doctor Cruz's smile melts away and swaps with a frown. "Volgrim world?" She glances at me. "What's that about?"

My heart does a gymnastic leap. *I haven't told anyone about Dosena's planet yet. I was hoping to keep that a secret for her sake.*

Samantha jumps in for the save. "No, Cass! We were *attacked* by the Volgrim! You must have passed out and become disoriented."

The succubus spends a minute explaining how we got here, and in the meantime, Beverly moves on and ignores the 'random babble' that Cassiel had said regarding a Volgrim world. *After all, a comatose patient can imagine a lot of things*, her eyes seem to say.

Cassiel, having apparently gotten the hint, nods along with Samantha. "So these people saved our lives? Wow! We owe them, don't we?"

"That would be excellent, yes." From the doorway, Beatrix's voice booms in the room. She strides in and saunters to the end of the bed, near Cassiel's feet. "We've been taking good care of you." It doesn't escape me that she glances over at Ionis, still standing in the corner, for a split-second. A look, not of fear, but of *desire* passes over her face, but she hides it quickly.

"Thank you so much!" Cassiel says, oblivious to the situation we're in. "We should definitely try and repay you!"

Despite the fact she's my girlfriend, I want to throttle her and tell her *shut up shut up!* It's not that the humans here are evil, but they're *humans*. Capable of tremendous empathy, but sociopathy as well, I can't ever fully trust them, especially if I know their motives and agenda. Unfortunately, I don't even fully understand that much about them.

While Cassiel smiles from ear to ear and pets Howard, Beatrix turns to me. "Jason, if you don't mind, can I have a few minutes of your time?"

"Sure."

She smiles at Cassiel again. "I'll just be bothering your fiance for a few minutes. It won't take long."

Cassiel turns white in the face, as does Samantha. "F-Fiance? What? Since when? What happened while I was out?!"

Beatrix's smile vanishes. "Oh. Maybe I misunderstood the situation. I assumed the three of you were a full item or on the road there."

I quickly reach out and pull Beatrix away while the girls *squee* to each other. "You're digging me a hole, here. What do you want to talk about?"

The commander points at the doorway. "It's private, for you only." Before I can retort with '*anything you want to say, you can say in front of the girls*,' she raises a finger to silence me. "No ifs, ands, or buts."

* * *

A few minutes pass, and we arrive in a small office space not far from the hospital room. As we step in, Beatrix presses a button to lock the door, then turns to me. "Before I tell you anything, I need your word you won't repeat it to anyone, including those two women, and especially not the demoness."

Her sudden change in attitude from smiling to that of a politician looking for easy money chills me. "Why would I promise that? I tell the girls everything."

"I'm sure you do. This is important though, more important than bedtime whisperings. Lives are at stake. If you don't promise, then... well, I don't know. You absolutely must hear this, so I guess we'll be in this room for a long time waiting."

Despite the mood shift, I casually lean against a wall and poke at a fake potted planet beside me. "Fine, whatever. This had better be good."

"Good? Not quite." Beatrix stiffens visibly, and takes a few moments to compose herself before speaking. "The Labyrinth has been thrown into chaos over the last few weeks. The humans were steamrolling the demons like they had been doing it for millions of years, but things have changed. The demons are mounting a major comeback. They've pulled out all the stops and are beating back the humans at every battle. If the situation worsens any more than it already has, a lot of good soldiers, and future allies, will die brutal deaths. I need you to go there and fix the situation."

The commander eyes me knowingly, and Marie's words return to my mind. *If you don't restore the balance of power; someone else will.*

"I've heard the Labyrinth isn't doing well. I'm planning to return soon." I pause, a sudden suspicion in my mind. "How do you know about the situation inside, though? Didn't you tell me a couple of days ago that you haven't contacted the Labyrinthian humans?"

Beatrix shuffles her feet and looks away. "You are correct. I haven't."

"So how do you know what the situation is?"

More discomfort. "As I've said, we can monitor Volgrim communications." She quickly turns back to me. "Anyway, that's not important. What's important is that I know what the situation is. My fellow humans could be aiding us in the war against the Volgrim and Kolvaxians, but they're busy fighting worthless demons. I need you to get back inside the Labyrinth and help defeat whatever is giving the demons their surge of power."

I can almost feel the tattoos glowing on my body as several thoughts occur to me. "No, it is important. You told me you didn't want me to tell Samantha anything. Why? Because she's a demon?"

"Because she's the second goddamn emperor, Jason." Beatrix hisses at me and takes a step forward. "I'm glad you're having fun with a cute little succubus girl, but that girl is the leader of demonkind in the absence of the First Emperor. The last thing I want is for her to know I can gather intelligence from inside the Labyrinth. Don't you see how-"

My hand jerks up instantly to stop her. "Hold on; you can gather intelligence from *inside* the Labyrinth? That's a different scenario from monitoring what the Volgrim are saying. What are you hiding?"

A guilty look disappears as quickly as it appears. "That isn't important. I can't trust Belial, not now, not ever. It's better you don't know."

Finally, I can put the puzzle pieces together. "You have a spy among the demons? More than one? Several?"

Instantly, Beatrix scowls. I hit the mark. "Why must you be so pushy? Nothing worse than a man who thinks he has a brain. YES! I have a few spies among the demons. What of it? Are you going to tell your girlfriend so she can have them eliminated?"

"I wouldn't do that."

"You wouldn't? So you can resist telling her the truth, then? And here I thought you loved her." Beatrix leans forward and stabs me in the chest with her finger. "I have put eons into these spies, and if I lose them, I lose my only intelligence connection to the inside. If you breathe a word of this to her, those demons are dead."

"Samantha wouldn't kill them or put their lives in danger. She doesn't give a damn about the political battles and wars." I lightly smack the commander's hand away and think to myself for a few moments. "How in the hell did you find demons that would betray their emperors? If there's one thing I know about demons, it's that they're fiercely hierarchical. Authority and respect mean everything to them. It can't have been easy."

The commander dodges my question again. "I do what has to be done."

"Did... did you brainwash them?" My memory flicks back to the device they used on Cassiel in the medical bay. "Are you forcefully converting demons to your cause?"

"No! Heavens, no! We just bribe them." Beatrix crosses her arms and shifts away from me, toward the door. *She's nervous*. "We aren't monsters."

"You aren't? Funny, I've met a lot of humans who I thought were worse than demons. Whatever you bribed these demon traitors with, it must have been pretty valuable-" My voice catches, and several things occur to me at once, all of them extremely unpleasant. "Jesus Christ. What did you bribe them with?!"

Beatrix eyes me evenly. "Leftovers."

"What? Something tells me you aren't talking about meatloaf."

"I'm not." She blinks slowly, pausing to close her eyes for a few moments. "I've made sacrifices. We all have. If it helps my crew survive for even another day, it's worth the tribute."

My stomach feels like I've just drunk a gallon of rancid milk. The thought that Beatrix is bribing demons with... with... *whatever* it is she's using, it disgusts me beyond all belief.

"Dictators and tyrants have used the same logic, Beatrix. From what Samantha has told me about demons, they don't value corpses nearly as much as they do fresh bodies. Since this must have been happening long before I liberated the Labyrinth, the demons already had access to humans in the bubble worlds. It's not just that you bribed them with live humans, but they had to be in a large enough quantity that it would be a worthwhile offer."

"Quality, not quantity." Beatrix almost whispers the words. "If you think what I've done doesn't keep me up at night, you're sorely mistaken. I'll just say it."

She takes a few deep breaths. "We gave them infants. Human infants. Those are forbidden in the Labyrinth. Humans have to grow to maturity before demons can devour them. It's the law set down by the Demon Emperors."

I'm not even shocked anymore. The revelation is so comically over-the-top that it has no effect on me.

"You gave live human babies to the demons, so that you could bribe them to be your spies. I'm... I'm just-" The words won't come out properly. I want to insult her, use my Wordsmithing to kill her, anything, but I can't. "Since you saved my life, and Samantha and Cassiel's, to boot, consider this my repayment for the debt. I will go back to the Labyrinth, and I will restore the balance of power, and I won't tell them what you've done. Normally, I'd be inclined to rip your guts out, so this is a real boon for you."

Beatrix shakes her head. "Death would be a mercy, Jason. You've only been awake for thirty years. I've been alive for tens of millions. The human psyche isn't designed to live that long, and mine certainly wasn't made to be a leader and the last hope for humanity for all those years. Killing me would be a mercy."

She glances at a picture of a man in a suit across the room. "I've considered doing it myself, as a matter of fact."

"I'll bet."

A digital clock on the wall shifts position from 17:09 to 17:10, and I tap my shoes together. This little chat has ruined my day. I want nothing more than to go to bed and never wake up

again from this awful nightmare. Years of my life spent tearing demons to bits, fighting clones of myself, battling the Volgrim, and for what? So I can liberate humans? Do they even deserve the privilege? If I defeat the demons, I'll just be handing the reins of power from one group to another. At least the demons, though they be flesh-eaters and disgusting creatures, understand order. They have traditions, and they're disciplined. Humans back-stab each other, lie, cheat, and steal over the smallest and most petty things. If something will give them the slightest leg-up in the world, they'll do it. Some people don't think that way, but the exceptions don't prove a rule.

Since neither of us apparently have anything left to say, I reach for the door-unlock button, but Beatrix reaches out and grabs my wrist. "You won't inform Belial of what I've told you, right?"

"I won't. I should, but I made a promise." I wrench away from her grasp and thrust the door open. A few minutes later, I stroll into the room to see Samantha and Cassiel poking Howard over and over while he *warks* and keeps trying to bite their fingers. Under normal circumstances, I'd probably laugh.

"Oh, Hero! You're back!" Cassiel smiles at me, her usual brilliant grin that could melt a glacier, but for once, I can't smile back. "Wanna play with Howard? If you poke his belly, he gets all flummoxed and-"

"If you're feeling better, Cass, we really should be going." I interrupt her before she can get too excited over her fun. "We've taken up enough of Beatrix's time and hospitality."

Samantha's smile is the first to vanish, but Cass's follows immediately after. "Is this about the talk you just had? I wasn't expecting for us to leave so quickly. What did you talk about?"

"This and that." I keep my words vague, despite wanting to tell her everything. "It's private. Anyway, let's get Cass cleaned up and ready to go. We're heading back to the Labyrinth."

"Oh. Okay..." Samantha's voice trails off.

Cassiel's expression is that of a wounded puppy. "But... they helped us so much. Don't we owe them at least a little bit?"

I turn away, unable to look both of them in the eyes. "Don't worry about the debt. We don't owe them a thing."

* * *

My ship powers up its thrusters silently, while I sit alone in the captain's seat. On the viewscreen, I watch the girls chatting with Doctor Cruz at the bottom of our entry-ramp, though I have the audio disabled. It's not my business to pry.

The silence on the Bridge is deafening.

Behind me, the rumbling of slow, plodding footsteps approaches. After a few moments, OMEN appears on my right side, his blank human-like face resting firmly in the Uncanny Valley. "Query: Why are we leaving ahead of schedule?"

"We're leaving right on time. It's a little impromptu, but I need to get back to the Labyrinth. I fucked the place up, so I'll be the one to unfuck it."

OMEN bobs his head, a bad imitation of a nod. "Observation: Based on your heart rate, blood pressure, body temperature, and multiple other physical tells, you are in a state of agitation. Speculation: This was caused due to a distressing event aboard the U.S.S. Terra. Query: Was my deduction correct?"

"You're annoying. Stop using the ship's sensors to look inside my body. It's creepy."

"Amused response: I believe my theory is correct. Thought experiment: Suppose you were to tell me about what happened. Don't you think you would feel much better?"

I roll my eyes up into my skull. "No. I wouldn't. Unless you can change the past and make humans a whole lot less shitty and depressingly predictable, you won't be any help."

The girls wave goodbye to Doctor Cruz and start walking up the exit ramp. "Objection: I am well versed when it comes to human psychological warfare and mental experimentation. It might be possible for me to change my programming in such a way that I could reverse-engineer my algorithms to calm your bodily functions. Why, you might even be able to sleep well, for once."

"I sleep just fine."

"Smug remark: You toss and turn all night long, every night. At least, ever since the angel female entered a comatose state. You are lying, but fooling nobody."

"Well, you're an asshole."

This seems to shut the robot up. "Amused response: Suit yourself. I was merely interested in prodding you for information. If you will not divulge anything, I will return to my recharge station in the cargo bay." Without another word, OMEN lumbers away.

Minutes pass, Cassiel and Samantha finally enter the bridge from a door behind me, and I hear nervous whispering, but I don't bother looking back. After a few seconds, Cassiel slips around my chair to my left side and smiles weakly at me. "Um, Hero? Are you okay? You look depressed."

"I'm a little down in the dumps, but it's nothing major."

I keep my voice neutral, but when Samantha pops up, her look of concern is even more worrying than Cassiel's. "If it's not a big deal, why are we leaving the station so soon? Cass didn't even get to look around, and you *know* how she loves technology and robots and stuff. I was telling her about the one that cleans the floors, but she didn't even get to see one."

I don't know what to say without revealing information. "We have to go. That's all there is to it. Ever since I spoke with Marie, I've known the Labyrinth was in a bad state, but now it's even worse off than when we spoke with her. Let's just leave and go fix things."

Samantha pauses, her eyes flick to Cass, then back to me. "There's something you're not telling us." It's not a question.

"Sam. I'd tell you anything and everything any other time. Just this once, I'd rather not. I made a promise."

Both girls look rather despondent as they limp over and flop in their chairs, but it can't be helped. It pains me to say nothing just as much as it hurts them. In a few days, we'll be over it. No big deal.

Cass sighs loudly as she taps on the console. "I do miss flying around in space. Where are we going?"

"I'll make a wormhole back to Volgarius Alpha. We'll re-enter the portal to the Labyrinth from there, and leave our ship with the humans on the planet. I could portal us to the Labyrinth directly, but we might need this ship in the future."

"Sounds like a plan." Samantha's tone is diplomatic, detached. "Let's get this over with."

Her rigid body language clearly makes Cassiel uncomfortable, but the angel says nothing. Soon, we blast out of the hangar without ceremony and fly over to a spot several thousand miles from the human ship as it cloaks behind us once again. Using my energy, I aim my mind at the void.

" Wormhole! "

A tremendous amount of energy sucks from my body, as space stitches together and creates a hole large enough for our ship to travel through. Not a minute later, I seal it behind us and sigh, as exhaustion suddenly overcomes me. "Put us down on the planet. I need to recover my energy, so I'll be sleeping in the back for a few hours."

I get out of my chair and wheeze, feeling my chest still hurt from the tiny bits of residual anti-energy. Cass turns around to me, a hopeful smile on her face. "If you're feeling bad, I know what'll cheer you up! Let's go to bed together, and-"

Sighing, I raise my hand to stop her. "Not this time, Cass. I don't want to be cheered up right now."

She doesn't even let out a disappointed whimper, as I leave the room.

Part 443c: Mercy

A familiar face greets me once again. My own.

My imposter and I stand facing each other, him at the edge of an unthinkably tall precipice, and me, not ten feet away. His grip on Samantha's throat tightens as he holds her over the cliffside.

" You thought you could protect them. It took a robot to save their lives, a machine of death, ironically enough. You were useless then, just as you are now. "

Samantha struggles and claws at my doppelganger's hand, but she can't fight his grip off at all. I take a step toward them, and he holds her a little further away. "Leave her alone. Your fight is with me. She didn't do anything to deserve this."

" She loves you. Killing her will hurt you far more than any wound of the flesh. I'll give you a moment to say your goodbyes. Don't waste it. "

"Don't you dare hurt her!" I jump at him, but he merely smiles at me, a cold, emotionless grin, as he loosens his grip. Samantha, surprised by the sudden movement, lets out a tiny squeak, before plunging off the edge of the cliff. Her scream muffles a second later, and by the time I stumble to the side of the cliff, she's gone.

"S-Samantha! No!"

The copycat paces around behind me and gazes down into the chasm. **" Oh dear, heh heh. She fell. And now, you will too. "**

Before I can react, he kicks me in the ass, sending me stumbling forward off the cliff. "Guh!"

My eyes squeeze shut as I brace for the feeling of rushing wind, but instead, a soft, beautiful voice whispers into my ear. "You don't have to do this alone. You don't have to be our bulwark. We can protect ourselves, Hero."

I blink my eyes open, and Cassiel's smiling face greets me. Her massive wings flap steadily, as she braces my body against hers, with my toes just barely touching the edge of the cliff. Samantha clutches onto Cassiel's back, one arm wrapped around Cass's shoulder, the other rubbing her neck.

"Cassiel is right, Jason. Just because you're a Hero, doesn't mean you have to save everyone. No-one can go at it alone."

" What?! " My copy takes a step back as Cassiel flaps again, shoving me to my feet at the edge of the cliff, as she and Samantha land a few feet away.

"You think we don't know who you are? You are the darkness. You wish to kill the purity inside Hero, but that's where you went wrong. Heroes never die."

The other me takes a step forward as he grabs a second wind. " **I am not darkness, I am strength. When the time comes, I will be the only way for you to save them. You will have a choice to make, and I will be your salvation. I will be your... hope. "**

Copycat Me whips his hand forward and aims his palm at us. " **Begone!** "

A wave of energy races forward, pushes us off the cliff, and our screams of terror rebound off the canyon walls as we plunge to our inevitable...

* * *

"...Demise!" I yell out awkwardly, suddenly realizing I'm staring at the ceiling of my bedroom again. Despite how erratic my breathing is, it calms down in seconds. "Just another nightmare..." I mutter sheepishly.

To my right and left, neither of the girls are here, so they left me alone for once. I lean up in bed and scratch my back as I stare vacantly across the room. *What I said to them earlier was messed up. An apology is top of my priority list.*

After a few minutes, my clothes are on, my face is shaved, and I'm ready to take on the day. A glance at the clock tells me I was out for around seven hours, so I slept better than expected. "Computer, where is the ship located?"

The AI's monotone voice answers immediately. "The One-Hundred-Fortieth Galactic Exploration Vessel has been landed on the surface of the planet of Volgarius Prime."

God, that's a terrible name for a ship, I think to myself. I suppose it doesn't matter since we'll be leaving it behind. Still...

"Computer, please rename the ship 'U.S.S. Pickle.'"

The computer takes a few moments to pause. *'Are you kidding me right now?'* I almost expect it to say. It doesn't.

"Command confirmed. This vessel has been renamed the U.S.S. Pickle on star-date 1.451.009. Are there any further commands?"

"No."

Saying that, I stride out of the room and down the hall to the Bridge. *It's high time I stopped lazing about and got to work,* I think to myself. The Labyrinth isn't going to fix itself.

My boots thud against the harsh metal floors and echo slightly around me as I walk. *How am I going to fix the Labyrinth anyway? Should I cage humans back in bubble worlds? That's*

stupid. Nobody should be forced to live like that, with demons feeding on them periodically. What a horrible way to go out. Should I force the demons to surrender? If I do that, the humans will probably kill them. Too much bad blood between them. I can't just expect both sides to back down and sing Kumbaya.

What if I forced them with Wordsmithing? I could make each side surrender and order them to never attack each other again. That would work, maybe.

But is it ethical? Should I just change their free will, as if I were a dictatorial god sent from on high to mold them to my beliefs? I barely even understand myself, let alone the nature of war and conflict. The humans have every right to lash out at the demons after the abuse they've suffered.

My thoughts slowly revolve around my brain, like a leaf spinning atop a whirlpool. Where does the vortex of philosophy lead? What is right? What is wrong?

The door to the bridge slides open, and I raise my head up from the ground. "I'm awake."

Only then do I realize the Bridge is empty. Nobody else is- wait, there's one 'person' here. OMEN.

The robot turns to look at me. "Initial greeting: Hello, Hero. I see that you have woken up. Condescension: Your dreams were as terrible as I expected, judging by how you tossed and turned. If only you had taken me up on my offer."

"Shut up. I can Wordsmith and make myself sleep like a baby anytime I want. I don't want a band-aid, I want to work things out properly. Anyway, where are the girls?"

The robot taps a button to show a lush forest outside the ship, with trees that wouldn't look out of place on Earth, and birds sitting atop the branches of the local flora. "Smooth transition while ignoring the brushing off of my offer: The two female non-humans are outside of the ship agitating local wildlife. Amused observation: Here you can see the winged one hurling sticks toward a group of vicious wolf-like animals."

Indeed, the screen changes to show Cassiel... playing fetch with a dozen or so random Border Collies, all while cooing and saying things like 'Get the stick! Good boy!'

"OMEN... you know she's just... playing with the dogs, right?"

The robot's face contorts into an eerie expression of mock horror. "Astounded response: I had no idea! Your keen eyes and insightful wisdom have changed my outlook on the meaning of life!"

"Wow, I didn't know you had a fucking sarcasm module installed." I roll my eyes and groan inwardly. "Where's Ionis?"

"Serious response: The only intelligent member of this crew, barring myself, is located inside the cargo bay. Observation: He has accomplished more in one week with this crew against the Volgrim than the human known as 'Hero' has since he arrived a month ago."

My tongue snakes out and wets my lips. "I swear, I'll teleport you into a star one of these days."

* * *

Slowly, the ramp extends down until it hits the forest's grass. The clearing around us is quite large, and trees surround us, almost as if this exact spot was made for the U.S.S. Pickle to land at. The girls are in the distance, playing with the group of dogs, but I stop and lean down to look at a flower on the ground. It looks like a tiny sunflower, as if someone hit it with a shrinking laser. A bug crawls around on the center of it, looking like a ladybug... but blue.

"I guess Wordsmithing and the Crown of Solomon didn't quite get all the details right," I mutter under my breath.

The girl's voices grow more audible as I head over to them. Cassiel nudges Samantha and points at one of the Collies. "-one I named Fluffy, because his tail is poofy! And this one over here is Dipsy, because he's kind of a doofus! And this pretty girl over here is Lora, because it's a pretty name for a cutie! If I had a daughter, that's what I'd call her!"

Samantha nods, but the look on her face is serious. "Dipsy is a condescending name though, don't you think? You don't want that boy to grow up to be a rebel outcast, do you? The other dogs will pick on him because he has such a silly name."

"No, no! It'll toughen him up! If everyone picks on him, then he'll become really strong and eventually he'll be like the alpha wolf or something!"

"I don't know if it works that way," Samantha says, clearly unconvinced. Before I can say anything, she turns just enough to spot me out of the corner of her eye. "Oh, you're awake!"

"Yup." I keep my tone neutral. "You two look like you're having fun."

Cassiel, apparently having already forgotten the way our conversation ended earlier, beams a radiant smile at me. "Are you here to play with the dogs too? This one is Hero Junior; I named him after you!"

One of the dogs turns and pants at me and immediately a look of revulsion passes over my face as I take a step back. "*Huagh!* What the fuck is wrong with his face?!"

The ugly hound has eight spider-like pitch-black eyes, and the two in the center are much bigger than the others. His innocent floppy tongue belies the horror of the upper half of his face. At my outburst he closes his mouth and bows his head, whimpering.

"Don't say that! Look, you made him sad." Cassiel leans down and hugs the wretched animal, kisses his forehead, and shoots a glare at me. "Apologize!"

I suddenly feel awkward, since I was initially going to apologize to her and Samantha for the way I treated them earlier, but now it feels awkward since she wants me to ask forgiveness to the dog first.

Might as well get this over with. I lean over and eye the ugly son-of-a-bitch up and down, swallowing my pride. "I'm sorry, Hero Junior. I didn't mean what I said. You're a *-hurgh-*, a good boy." The fearsome animal stares back at me and gives me a lick on the chin, just to spite me.

I turn back to Cassiel, but she speaks before I can. "And now us."

"Huh?" My look of dopiness makes her and Samantha snort to each other.

Sam pokes me in the shoulder. "You've apologized to the dog. Now, what about us? You were awfully rude, earlier."

Guilt washes over me. "Um. I was actually going to do that before you, uh..." *I feel so stupid.* I should have just said it quickly. I'm awkward in situations like this. "I'm sorry. I was in a bad mood after what Beatrix told-" I catch myself as the girls' smiles vanish. "-Well, that is, it's not important. I was wrong, and I apologize."

Cass curls up her lip and looks at Sam. "I guess it'll do."

"Yeah. Could have been more heartfelt, but he's just a guy after all."

"Hey... I'm standing right here, you know."

* * *

The portal back to the Labyrinth yawns before us. Cass glances back at the forest. "I kinda like it here. Do we have to go back? It's so dark and dreary inside."

"We have to. Humans and demons are fighting, and I need to find out what the situation is."

Samantha leans against me and yawns. "So what are you going to do? Kill more demons? Kill humans? Put them in a corner and time them out?"

"I don't know, Sam. I'm still wondering how I should proceed. I'll think about it."

Cassiel offers her input. "Timing them out seems pretty reasonable to me. Just make sure they don't peek. Nose to the wall!"

We'll call that Option B, I think to myself.

The portal swallows us up as we step through, and the all-consuming darkness of the labyrinth is barely illuminated by the sunlight from Volgarius Prime. The corridor stretches

ahead, and its dampness makes our footsteps sound *sloshy* compared to the dry ground from outside. *Was it always this mossy?*

Cassiel's soft glow radiating from her body doesn't light up much, so I make my own source of brightness. " **Illuminate!** "

A ball of bright energy, not unlike Hoarhiim's orb, appears and hovers above us, like a 300w lightbulb. It's bright enough that it easily shows us the caverns around and before us, but by focusing my mind, I can force the light to radiate in any desired direction. Knowing this, I make it brighten up the path far into the distance.

"Wish I'd had this when I first got out of the Cryopod," I mutter to myself.

Apparently hearing me, Cassiel responds, "A most impressive display."

Minutes turn into an hour, as the Crown of Solomon's mental map leads us down this path and that one, left and right, up and down, toward the place I called Home for a short while; Hero City. Sometimes I see walls that look familiar, and remember the ten years I spent exploring this Labyrinth.

The shifting walls and ways the Labyrinth reconfigures itself is a mystery. How did a place like this come to be? Why is it so massive, like the size of ten Suns from the Terran system? How does it even make sense for the Labyrinth to work in the way it does?

Samantha sighs. "Do you know where you're going? I feel like we've looped around five times already."

"My mental map is three-dimensional and comprehensive. It's a little incredible how well it works." We stop in front of a path split in three directions to look around. From the end of one hallway, an odd *clink*, like the sound of an empty plastic bottle being bopped against the floor. When I shine my light down the hall, I'm surprised to see undead skeletons slowly shambling toward us.

Samantha curls up her lips. "Ugh, necromancy. I am not a fan. So uncute."

Neither she nor Cassiel looks particularly concerned by the creatures holding swords and shields. Cassiel swipes a strand of hair from her face. "How do the skeletons move, anyway? Who makes them?"

"Dunno. Well, I think there are some demons whose magical abilities relate to raising the dead, but it's a stereotype that they're always ugly-looking impish skugs, so I never got to know any of them." Samantha takes a step back, "Sadly, these bony fellows are probably better looking than their masters."

With that, she lunges forward, at a speed that takes me by surprise. Moving like water through a series of pipes, she ducks, dodges, and bats the weapons from each skeletons' hand, crushing each of their skulls in her grip by clapping with a tremendous force. Each skeleton falls to pieces on the ground and doesn't get back up.

After destroying the two dozen or so, Samantha skips back over to us, whistling daintily the whole way, before thrusting her hands in front of me. "Could you be a dear and clean my hands off? They're filthy now."

" **Clean.** " With a single word, the powdered bones are cleaned from her hands, and Cassiel smiles giddily.

"That was so cool, Sammy! You kicked their- well, I was going to say 'butts,' but you crushed their heads, so I guess that doesn't make sense. Hmm." Her excitement vanishes as the strange philosophical questions of *butts versus heads* appears in her mind. "Well, given those were, you know, demonic skeletons, don't you feel bad about killing them?"

The question sends a wave of visible disgust washing across Samantha's face. "Oh, seven hells, no! Skeletons are disgusting, creepy creatures. I always like to put them out of their misery. I have no particular affinity toward generic monsters either, but I try not to harm other demons. They're kin, after all."

We take off down the opposite path as more questions occur to me. "Where do monsters come from, if they're not demons? Do demons create monsters, like orcs and goblins?"

Samantha adjusts the strips of fabric barely covering her body. "Well, humans like to pretend that monsters are from myths and legends, or rather, they preferred to at one point, but monsters have always been around. They were violent and didn't quite catch on with the human populace, since they aren't cute and cuddly, you see. The monsters in the Labyrinth were once on Earth, but they moved inside the Labyrinth at some point before Earth's destruction."

I raise an eyebrow. "So... who created them?"

"No idea." Samantha's curt reply makes me drop the subject.

A few minutes later, Samantha stops suddenly as we round a corner. Cass and I pause as the succubus squints and looks up ahead. "Now, that's odd."

In the distance, the sound of bare feet pattering catches up to us as dozens of goblins and orcs round the corner. Each of them is armed to the teeth, and the moment they spot us, a bloodthirsty look enters their eyes.

This time, I step up to bat. "I'll take care of these, Sam. Even if they aren't demons, it's not right that you should kill them."

Samantha chews on her lower lip. "No, Hero, this is odd. I sense a larger amount of energy in their bodies compared to their expected amount, and they seem much more vicious than they should be."

Cassiel's usually cheerful expression is gone, replaced with a darker one. "Need a second opinion? The energy in their bodies is twisted and malformed. It's as if they're consumed with rage."

"I agree," Samantha says, as she glances at me. "I would normally prefer we don't kill them, but... a fight might be unavoidable."

The goblins and orcs begin charging down the corridor, and Cassiel's expression brightens. "I have an idea!"

Saying that, she aims her hand at the horde charging forth. I feel an odd sensation in the air, and a moment later, confusion spreads across their faces, then they stop moving and flop forward to the ground. Cassiel smiles, "Piece of cake. I gave them a nice snooze."

"Maybe when they wake up they'll be less cranky," Samantha mumbles.

I teleport the three of us past them, wondering privately to myself why I didn't just teleport us to a different floor before, and after a few more minutes of walking, Samantha sighs. "Oh, brother. I hate to be the bearer of bad news, but we're being followed, Hero."

"We are? By who?" I look behind and in front of us, but Samantha shakes her head.

"I don't know by who, exactly, but they're a demon of tremendous power. She or he is following us and keeping a distance, but probably doesn't know I can feel the aura of anger from here. Seriously, the weird emotion in the Labyrinth is so out-of-place compared to normal. I wonder what's going on?"

A few ideas come to mind, but since I'm unsure, I keep them to myself. "Let's find a bigger area where we can face this demon and spread out. If they're as powerful as you say, I'd rather not take any chances."

Using my mental map, I trace a path to one particularly sizeable nearby room, and as we run, Samantha looks increasingly more and more agitated. "Still following us, and picking up the pace too. I think they're getting closer..."

We hurry around one last corner and step into a large chamber, one that immediately makes me cock an eyebrow. The room is very familiar. A pedestal sits in the center, and the room is filled with gold and jewels, but it takes me a moment to recognize the place.

It's the room where I first found Hoarhiim.

Indeed, the pedestal sits by itself, but the three statues I remember from before are missing. The gold and jewels are still everywhere, but the room looks *different* from how I remember. *Odd.*

Samantha, Cassiel and I turn around and face the hallway from whence we came. It takes a whole minute, but Samantha tenses up. "They're here."

From around the corner, a long beak appears, filled with razor-sharp teeth. A scaled monster I've seen before steps from around the corner, standing nearly as tall as me. His clubbed tail thumps against the wall, as if to announce his entrance, and his clawed talons clench as he spots us.

"Hoho, it seems I've found my prey. The human and the angel who escaped me once, as well as..." He pauses to squint at Samantha. "The Second Emperor in the flesh? It's my lucky day."

Cassiel's body trembles slightly, but she keeps up a brave face. "Gressil. I've been thinking about you a lot lately."

I glance at her, trying to keep a neutral expression. *You have?* I want to ask, but don't.

A long forked tongue slips out of Gressil's mouth as he takes a menacing step forward. "Interesting, my pretty angel. I've thought about you as well. All of my angelic prisoners are dead, and you were the last. I've been *dying* to put you back where you belong."

Nobody says a word for a few seconds, but Samantha gently pulls Cassiel behind her. "I don't care how strong you think you are, Gressil. If you want to hurt my friend, you'll have to go through me first. You're overestimating your chances of winning here."

"I don't need to *win*." Gressil's reply comes immediately. "I just want my prisoner back. Is that too much to ask, *Second Emperor*? Look at you, snuggling up to a human and an angel. You're a disgrace to the demons. It's no wonder the First had to step up to fix the mess this 'Hero' has caused."

The blood drains from Samantha's face. "Th-the First Emperor? He's- he's working now?"

Gressil chuckles. "Kukuku... you don't know? Ah, that's right, you've been away from home for a while, haven't you? The pests have risen to fight the demons, and until recently, they were cleaning us right up! But thanks to the power of the First, we're taking back the Labyrinth from the worthless meatbags."

Samantha's eyes widen as she looks at me. "This explains a lot..." Her voice is nearly a whisper. "The First Emperor is aiding the demons now. Unless you help them, the humans are finished."

The monstrous demon chuckles again. "Now you see the error of your ways. If you'll be so kind as to give me my prisoner back, I'll overlook this transgression. The First doesn't need to know about your betrayal." He snickers to himself and turns to Cassiel. "I look forward to hearing your whimpering and begging once more. It has been quite boring without you to entertain me. You were always my favorite, you know."

"I've had just about enough of this." I take a step forward and reach toward him, but Cassiel bats my hand away.

"No, Hero. Violence isn't the answer. I don't hate Gressil. He may be a monster, but he's not a monster just because he's a demon. Samantha has shown me that much. As bad as Gressil is, I won't take revenge, and I won't let him control my life. I'm free, now."

Gressil blinks twice. "You're not afraid of me? As if you think I can't see your soft, pale flesh trembling. You're quaking in terror. You remember the shape of my claws, the ripping of my talons against your skin. I doubt the scars have healed, especially the ones in your heart."

Cassiel shakes her head. "I'm not scared of you. In a way, I... I pity you. When I was alone in that cell, I hated knowing you would return- but at the same time, I wanted you there, rather than the silent emptiness around me. In a way, you were my only friend. If you hadn't been there, I would have withered away and died."

Gressil's usual confidence cracks slightly. "A friend? Impossible. Who could be friends with their torturer? You sound delusional! Perhaps your mind cracked under an eternity of torture. Breaking you was always one of my deepest desires... and it would seem I achieved that goal."

"You're sick. A vile evil creature." Samantha hisses the words out and clenches her fist, but Cassiel stops her again.

"He can't help the way he is, Sammy. If there's anyone I should hate, it's humans. Many humans experimented on myself and the other angels, through awful periods of pain and suffering that would make you weep. Gressil, however, was just one demon. He doesn't represent the rest of them. From what I know of demons, they follow a hierarchy, so he was assigned to be a prison warden, and that's what he became. He adapted to his job, and he enjoyed it. He made the best of a bad situation."

Samantha and I both are in shock. She's the first to verbalize. " *The best of a bad situation?* Cass, he's a psychopathic monster. You're being way too forgiving here."

"Yes, but that's my choice." Cassiel takes a tentative step toward the menacing demon. "Gressil, sometimes you scare me, but I still forgive you. I would consider you an ally, even, if you were to change your ways."

For once, the monstrous demon is at a loss for words. "You...! I can't just- what?! Foolish little-!"

He stutters and stammers, and I stare at Cassiel in shock. "You take pacifism to a new level, Cass. This is out of the ordinary, even for you."

She shakes her head. "It's not like that, Hero. I have to lead by example. You're always itching for a fight, and you always want to solve problems with your fists, but that's not the right way to do things. If I can't forgive Gressil, I can't teach you how to put an end to war."

Gressil finally seems to have cleared his head. He sighs. "I suppose in the end, I didn't break you. I'll just have to torture you more and more, until I finally do."

A glint appears in his eye. Gressil lunges forward with his tail, aiming to wrap around Cassiel's throat just as he did to me. Before I can react, Samantha dashes forward, batters his tail out of the way, and delivers a colossal blow to his abdomen. A violent explosion of blood blasts out behind him and a wave of energy rocks the room around us. Gressil's feet talons dig into the ground, somehow holding him in place for a second before his upper body rips from his legs and smashes into the wall on the other side of the room.

Not a sound escapes his lips at any point during the brutal slaughter.

Cassiel stares at his corpse numbly. "Sam... Sam... why? You shouldn't have interfered. I- I was going to change him!"

Samantha shakes her head, and when she turns back to look at Cassiel and me, I notice the amount of brown blood covering the front of her body. "You're wrong. Gressil was set in his ways. He would have hurt you, and I can't allow that. Fellow demon or not, you matter more to me than he does. If someone tries to cause you harm, I'll end them."

Cassiel's lip quivers as she fights back tears. "I can- I can protect myself! Hero has given me all this energy, this power! I could have destroyed Gressil with a thought... it wasn't about whether I was in danger, it was about my conviction! Why can't you see that?!" The sadness in her voice turns to anger as the tears finally roll down. "I wanted to show you that love conquers hatred! All you've done is show that anger leads to more violence!"

As Cassiel yells, images from a memory I can't place of her destroying Gressil with an energy beam enter my mind. "She's right, Samantha. This was her battle to fight. You've hurt her by undoing her act of forgiveness. I'm glad you stood up for Cass, but that was the wrong way to do it."

Samantha pivots and glowers at me. "You're taking her side in this? Gressil was going to attack her, and you would have let him do it! Where's your masculine pride and chivalry?"

Cassiel quickly calms down, though she can't stop staring at Gressil's warm, quivering corpse. "Sammy, he was no danger to me. You jumped the gun, and now he's dead. You didn't have to do that, and shouldn't have. Is that what you're going to do when we see the humans? Are you going to kill every demon that has a bone to pick with the last remaining angel?"

"Well... no..." Samantha's indignation softens and is replaced with embarrassment. "I wouldn't go that far."

"Then think before you punch." Having delivered her verbal backhand, Cassiel sighs deeply. "Well, what's done is done. He's dead." She squints at the body. "I didn't even see you move. Are you really that fast?"

Samantha smiles slightly. "Strong, too. You know that the Emperors are the strongest of all demons, right? Even powered up by the First, Gressil never stood a chance."

"Good to know," I mutter quietly. "Let's get a move on. Our little detour has cost us more time, but luckily this room is close to the entrance to Hero City. We'll be there sooner than you expect."

Both girls nod, and as we head out the opposite exit, Cassiel turns back to Gressil's corpse one last time. "Sometimes I'm not sure why I even bother."

Part 444c: Commander Unit

It's the shiver down my spine that gives his sudden appearance away, long before I turn around and spot the killer robot. I rub my arms just as my eyes meet Ionis's single, beady red diode. Samantha and Cassiel turn around only a second later and spot him too.

"Uh... Ionis? What are you doing here? Weren't you in the cargo hold when I left with the girls?"

I'm surprised he managed to find us. The Labyrinth is a maze of twisting corridors, shifting walls and hallways that move around dynamically. Only an evil genius could have made a tunnel network that outdoes a million stacked together Rubik's Cubes at boggling the mind.

Ionis swivels his eye from each of the girls to me, and only now do I realize he's cradling that damn duck in his arms.

THIS SENTINEL UNIT'S HIGHEST PRIORITY IS PROTECTING THE FEMALE ANGEL-TYPE ORGANIC. ONCE YOUR ABSENCE WAS DISCOVERED, THIS SENTINEL IMMEDIATELY MOVED TO LOCATE YOU.

Samantha nudges me. "What's Stinky saying?"

She still calls him that? "He followed us to protect Cassiel. I guess he brought her duck, too."

Cassiel *squees* and hops giddily as she takes Howard away from Ionis. "I was worried that OMEN was going to forget to feed him, but now it won't be a problem! Thanks, Ionis, you're so sweet!"

My hands slowly rub together as I eye the giant death-machine down. "Yeah, Ionis, *thanks* for bringing the duck. How'd you find us, anyway?"

I LOCATED YOUR UNIQUE ENERGY SIGNATURES AND RAPIDLY TRAVELED TO THIS LOCATION VIA USAGE OF MY INCINERATOR BEAM.

"Incinerator beam?" It takes me a few seconds, but I suddenly realize what he means. Pulling up my mental map, I'm stunned to see a giant hole straight from the portal to Voldarius Prime straight to our current location. When I look past the robot, I spot a gaping hole sliced into the wall at the end of the tunnel. "Holy hell."

Samantha sees what I'm looking at and gets the picture before I can even explain. "Did he really cut a path directly here? Satan would be pissed if he found out. The Labyrinth is ruined." A pause as she taps her lip. "Well, the Labyrinth will repair the hole given time. It'll probably take a day or two at most. I'm overexaggerating, as usual."

Howard *warks* and Cassiel looks more thoughtful than usual. "The Labyrinth repairs itself? How does that work?"

"Magic." Samantha chuckles. "It feeds off trace amounts of the energy of its inhabitants and slowly expands over time, while also repairing any damage it suffers. It's much more versatile than his first Labyrinth. Easier to hide from invaders, too."

"Because of the shifting hallways?" I give her a look that says *yes, I know about those*.

"Mhm."

She doesn't say anything else, but I get the picture. Satan built this Labyrinth. No wonder it's so annoying. Even dead, he's a nuisance.

After a few moments, I turn back to Ionis. "Well, I guess if you're here, you're here. I kinda didn't want to bring you in front of the humans, but if they have anti-energy, you might be useful in a fight."

"Not that we'll be fighting," Cassiel says with a suspicious look on her face. "I think there's already been enough of that."

"Yeah, haha." Samantha giggles nervously.

As we turn back to the great door that leads inside Hero City, I glance at the duck in Cassiel's arms. "Ionis, why'd you bring the duck, anyway? Seems kinda pointless to me."

THOSE WERE THE COMMANDER UNIT'S ORDERS.

"Uh, no?" I cock my head back and shoot a quizzical look at him. "I never said anything of the sort."

THE HUMAN-TYPE ORGANIC KNOWN AS JASON HIRO IS NOT THE COMMANDER UNIT.

Now I'm really confused. "Okay, who is, then?"

THE COMMANDER UNIT IS DESIGNATED HYPER-INTELLIGENT UNKNOWN-CLASS UNIT DESIGNATED 'HOWARD'.

Several seconds. Perhaps ten. That's how long I silently stare at Ionis. Taking a step to the side, I wrap my arm around Samantha's shoulder and whisper quietly to her.

"Hey. Sam."

She gives me a weird look but keeps her voice low. "What? Did he say something?"

"The death robot that can exterminate entire species thinks the duck is the commander unit."

"Oh." Samantha looks unconvinced. "He said that?"

"Mhm."

Sam's eyes flick to Cassiel, who is politely keeping out of our whispered conversation, but seems annoyed she isn't being included.

"That's the dumbest thing I've ever heard."

I nod. "My thoughts exactly. Should we tell Cass?"

"She might actually believe him. It'll go to her head. Better make up something else."

"I don't know if I can think of anything right now. I'm still in shock."

"You're a smart guy. Use your other head if you have to."

"Clever girl."

Carefully shambling past Samantha, I slide over to Cass. "Ionis has declared his eternal, undying love for you. I didn't want to tell you because it seemed so out of left field, but now you know why he never says anything to you and Samantha. He's shy around girls."

"Ohhh." Cassiel's eyes light up. "That *does* make sense, now that I think about it."

Oh my god. She took the bait.

Nodding slowly, I turn back to stare at Ionis, ignoring Cassiel's *oohs* and *ahhs* as she meditates on the importance of being a good wife to a genocidal murder machine.

"Your secret is safe with me, Ionis."

Ionis stares me down. *WHAT IS LOVE?*

I guess he heard me whispering to Samantha.

"It's what you feel toward Cassiel. Let's get a move on. My head is going to explode if I hear any more about your latest... opinions." A snicker from Samantha makes me whirl to face her. "I mean the head on my shoulders. Your mind is filthy."

Blankly, I turn and stare at the door. It still hasn't *hit me* that the Sentinel follows the orders of a fucking duck, but it certainly explains why he's not half as intelligent as OMEN. OMEN would never say something so dumb even if he were ordered to.

Coiling up the muscles in my arm, I give the colossal, towering doors a shove, and they quickly swing open.

The light spills out into the hallway, and a group of men in uniform spin and spot us. The door guardsmen I set to guard the entrance, it seems, and they noticed us immediately. Looks like discipline hasn't slackened since I left.

"You! Who goes there?" An Arabian looking man steps forward, wearing a grey and blue uniform, with the symbol of a winged tiger on his chest. His flat cap is colored a dark maroon, and judging by his muscles, he stays fit.

He quickly looks at Cassiel, then me, but when his gaze turns to Samantha, his eyes size her up and down, but they don't freeze on her chest as most men do, but instead on her tail. "Wench, are you a demon? No demons allowed. You're lucky I'm a tolerant fellow, or I'd have a platoon here in an instant. As for the man..." He turns to glare at me. "No horns, no tail, but if you think that dark skin and the glowing tattoos don't out you as an Animus, you'd be quite wrong. Two demons, an angel, and a robot. If you leave at once, I won't do anything hasty."

Everything he's just said makes no sense at all. It takes me a couple seconds to come up with an answer. "What do you mean, 'no demons allowed'? Who came up with a stupid rule like that?"

His eyes widen, and he puts his hands on his hips. The other men behind him slowly reach for their small-arms, and one spits a cigar on the ground. "Well well, seems someone's a little behind on the times. Do you take me for a fool, animus? We haven't taken a single one of your kind for weeks. If you don't leave in five seconds, you'll think death was a mercy."

His arrogance is starting to piss me off. "I'm not an animus, nor am I a demon. I'm Hero, you moron. The one who founded this city, Hero City. The one who freed humanity. Don't tell me that after one month everyone's gone and forgotten my face so quickly."

The look of contempt on his face loses a tiny bit of its bite as he squints and studies me for a few moments. "You don't look anything like him. I worked with one of his clones for a while, before the Clone Wars. In fact, you look like his polar opposite. Anyway, even if you *are* Hero, we certainly don't want you here. That's why the king banished you, fool."

"Banished me?" Now I'm bewildered. "Since when?!"

"You call yourself 'Hero,' and you don't even know? Obviously for tearing the city apart with your damned clones. How short do you think our memories are? You even planted demon traitors in our midst, assuming you're actually him."

One of the other guys, a morbidly obese man wearing what can only be described as several layers of blankets, coughs into his hand. "You tell him, Renji. Ain't got no room for magical mumbo-jumbo or scum-suckin' demon trash in our fair city."

Cassiel gnashes her teeth. "How rude! Despicable! And you call yourselves human?! Humans are supposed to be compassionate and empathetic, not bigoted and filled with irrational hatred! Just because you're warring with the demons doesn't mean all demons are bad! Hero built this

city with his magic, and he freed you from the clutches of that snake lady person! You owe him your lives, and your respect!"

"I don't owe you three a goddamn thing!" Renji lashes out and steps toward us as he reaches for an anti-energy pistol at his side. "Demons tried to kill the king after we gave them safe harbor! Hero and his clones trashed this city! Demons killed many of my friends! Don't come asking us for safe harbor and act like you can lord over us with a false identity!"

He draws his pistol, and I've had enough. " **Sleep.** "

"What?" The last thing he says before his eyes slam shut is somewhat anticlimactic. He flops to the ground, as do all the other men at the entrance.

"The hell is going on?" I glance back at Ionis. "From this point forward, you are not to attack or harm anyone at all, unless they incapacitate all three of us. I'll handle whatever happens myself. Understand?"

Ionis looks from me to Howard and back again. *THE ORDER CONTRADICTS THE COMMANDER UNIT'S ORDERS. THIS SENTINEL UNIT WILL NOT COMPLY.*

It takes all of my control not to facepalm so hard my palm crashes through my skull and reduces my brain to jelly. "If you attack the humans or anger them, they will turn their full might against us, including Cassiel, and she might die. Do you want-" I pause and remember what I told her earlier. "Do you want Cassiel, your lover, to die? That's what will happen if you piss them off. Isn't that right, Howard?"

I turn to the duck and whisper under my breath " **Agree.** " Immediately, the duck nods.

This satisfies Ionis. *UNDERSTOOD. THIS SENTINEL UNIT WILL COMPLY WITH THE ORDER NOT TO HARM ANY OF THE HUMAN-TYPES IN THIS AREA.*

He really does take orders from the duck. My head hurts.

Quickly, we step over the bodies and an idea occurs to me. "This is just a temporary measure. **Disguise. Disguise. Disguise. Disguise.** "

Aiming my mind at each of the girls and myself, I remove my odd tattoos, make Samantha's tail invisible and cover her up a little bit so she doesn't stand out, and hide Cassiel's wings and glow. Somehow, she looks less regal and queenly without them.

"Ew, clothes." Samantha writhes uncomfortably, as if the few extra scraps of fabric were made up entirely of maggots and flesh-eating bacteria. "Do I have to?"

Cassiel reaches behind herself and bumps something invisible. "My wings are still there?"

"It's just a disguise. Samantha has her tail, too. I could morph them away if I need to, but I think both of you wouldn't feel right. As for-" I pause, realizing Ionis hasn't changed at all. I intended for him to turn into a giant Russian man, but nothing happened. "Ionis, why don't you look different?"

His eye swivels down and examines his chassis. *THIS SENTINEL UNIT IS COATED IN A MICROSCOPIC LAYER OF THE SUBSTANCE DESIGNATED 'ANTI-ENERGY.' ENERGY OTHER THAN TYPE ONE WILL BE NULLIFIED AS A RESULT.*

"Everyone and their mother has anti-energy these days," I mutter under my breath. "If I bring you with us, you'll stick out like a sore thumb."

Samantha suddenly looks excited. "I have an idea! Make a bunch of fake skin, then put it on him and cover him up with a bunch of robes. He'll still stand out, but people will just think he's a blind man following after us or something."

I nod. "Good idea. Not perfect, but anything will do."

Several minutes later, I stare in disgust at the final product. "If anyone asks, he's a mute acid-attack victim."

Cassiel slowly licks her lips. "He's maybe the most disgusting thing I've seen in my life."

"I think it's an improvement," Samantha jokes with a wry smile. "At least he looks less robotic."

"He looks like a Terminator that got half-melted during time travel." A pang of sickness ripples in my stomach as I eye the freakish lumps and folds of skin covering the metal frame. "At this point, the robes are for my protection. I don't want to have to look at you."

After wordsmithing some giant shirts, pants, and a bunch of cloaks, I can barely see under his hood. His eye is covered, but when I ask if he can still see, he responds with: *THIS SENTINEL UNIT IS CAPABLE OF SENSING THE ENVIRONMENT IN ANY DIRECTION FOR UP TO 1000KM IF THE SITUATION CALLS FOR IT.*

I guess that's a yes.

The door closes behind us as I use my wordsmithing to seal it up and hide the sleeping men under tarps, and we begin to make our way downtown.

Immediately, I realize this isn't the Hero City I left a month ago. Before, it was a bustling metropolis, with buildings multiple stories tall and a Victorian feel to it, combined with an aesthetic similar to Arthurian and Viking legends. Chapels to unknown gods, marketplaces filled with food grown offworld, many such things were part of this capital I once knew.

But now...

A child sits on a stool, a glum expression on his face, as he slowly lowers and raises his foot in and out of a shallow puddle of mud. His clothes are ragged, and his demeanor is that of defeat. Sadly, he is not the only one. Aside from a few women quietly chatting with each other in a group, the street full of people has a despondent depression hanging in the air. It's only when I spot a man in a military uniform leaning on crutches, with a bandaged leg, missing one of his hands, and trying awkwardly to make the crutches work for him, do I realize just how bad things have become.

Samantha inhales slowly. "I wasn't here long, but the place has certainly changed. The war must be worsening for the humans."

At least she doesn't sound happy about it. Cassiel pats Howard's head. "I'm going to go talk with that little boy over there." Saying this, she takes off to the boy splashing in the mud puddle. Samantha and I watch curiously as she bends down and flashes her radiant smile at him. Despite whatever was making him sad, he's delighted to see such a beautiful woman talking to him. Not even twelve years old, and the poor lad looked like he was on the verge of suicide until she showed up.

A minute later, her smile is gone. The boy's is, too.

She finally trudges back over to us. "Both of his parents were in the military. Demons killed them. He's been an orphan for only a week."

Samantha's gaze lowers. "I'm sorry to hear that. War is hard on both sides."

"Sounds like the demons are putting up quite a fight." I scratch my nose and stare at the boy whose eyes are fixated entirely on Cassiel. "Did he say anything else?"

"He doesn't like demons. Nobody does. They tried to kill King Cody, but he survived." Cass pauses and glances at Sam before continuing. "All the demons have been taken away."

"What does that mean?" Samantha tries desperately to hide a look of revulsion but fails miserably.

"He didn't know. He's just a child, after all. Wherever the demons are being taken, they never return."

As if a blizzard had just decided to sweep through the alley, I rub my arms as a strange coldness falls over me. "Is this really Cody, the man who led the Gold Battalion? Didn't you work with him, Samantha? I didn't think he was like this."

She lightly chews on her thumb. "I don't know. He loved torching Grez. He saw the power I could unleash. If he was attacked by demons, anything is possible."

Cassiel sets Howard on the ground, and he hops up and down, *warking* in front of her. "We should pay him a visit, don't you think? Let's get to the bottom of this and-"

"MAKE WAY!" A man shouts, his voice filled with alarm. "Clear the streets! We've got wounded incoming!"

As if by magic, every man, woman, and child leaps into doorways and alleys, leaving just the four of us dumbfounded as the sound of marching feet, like hail on a stone roof, come stomping toward us from further down the street. Dozens, if not hundreds of soldiers move toward us, hauling hundreds of other men and women on stretchers or other medical mobility devices. The three of us quickly start to move to the side, but Ionis continues standing perfectly still like an idiot.

"Ionis! Get over here! Stop standing in the street!" Cassiel hisses at him, and he quickly complies, stepping into the doorway along with us.

The soldiers march past, looks of pain and mental wounds apparent on their faces. One man weeps and clutches an ice pack to his face, and a gaping burn wound just barely sticks out from under his hand.

It takes many minutes as the horde of women and men washes past us, but soon, they're gone.

An old lady steps out onto the street and sighs. "How many did we lose today?"

Another responds in kind. "Too many. Did you see the boy? How can they send such young children out to fight?"

"He's sixteen. That's old enough for the king."

A bum sitting across the street chuckles. "At least it ain't me." He slurps down a mystery liquid in a metal canister hanging from his side. "I'm done sticking my neck out for that no-good tyrant."

"You never did in the first place! And that 'tyrant' is protecting us!" Both old women glower at the bum, but he just shrugs.

"Yeah, sure looks like he's doin' a mighty fine job. Demons'll tear us to pieces in a month or two. At least the rum will dull the pain."

"Ignore him, Agatha. Lee's always like this." The second woman pulls the first away, and both of them quickly scurry over to a market stall where some suspect-looking tomatoes are being sold, all the while shooting dirty looks at the old bum.

Samantha and Cassiel both look at each other, then at me. "The people seem divided about the King," Cassiel says, "and the war isn't going well either by the sound of it."

The succubus shrugs and leans against the wall. "Once the First Emperor became involved, the humans lost immediately. It's just a matter of time."

"Not if I can help it." I pull both of them along with me, and Ionis follows close behind us. "It's time we paid the king a little visit. I think he'll be unhappy about what I have to say."

As we pass a building that smells like a fermented outhouse, one thought comes to my mind:
What tore apart Hero City in the single month I've been gone?

Part 445c: Meet The King

Stealth was on the table for at least a minute. I considered sneaking into the palace to see what was going on, but then it occurred to me that this is Hero City, named after me, the one who saved it. Even if a few morons think I was banished, or a few guards don't recognize me, I'm still ultimately the highest authority here.

With that in mind, I decide to take the bold strategy and walk in through the front door. The lofty stone wall and gate in front of the palace is a surprise, as are the security guards in front of it. Those weren't there when I left.

"Who goes there?" A greeting identical to the one I received when I entered Hero City is uttered by a blonde woman with a commanding presence. Along with a couple strongmen at each side of the closed gate, she looks to be someone large and in charge.

"I'm Hero. The guy who freed this city from Bahamut. I need to speak with King Cody."

Her lip twitches. "I would remind you that His Excellency is now being referred to by his last name, Elshard. In any case, I do not recognize you." Her eyes flick to Samantha and Cassiel, who both look like humans now, then to Ionis, whose humongous body is hidden under rags and blankets to the extent even his face is invisible. His glowing red eye is shielded, of course.

"Right. King Elshard. Well, if you don't know my face me, perhaps a third party will?" I glance down at my arm just to check and see if my glowing tattoos are visible, but they aren't.

Samantha pipes up. "I worked with a man named Saul, directly under Cody- err, King Elshard, for a while. This was before he was king. Saul, Gunther, either one can confirm our identities."

The blonde woman's demeanor instantly becomes more somber. "Ah, I regret to inform you that as of five days ago, Gold Division Leader, Saul Lorenz, was killed by a demonic ambush. We lost many good men and women in that battle. He won't be able to vouch for you."

Samantha doesn't seem particularly hurt by the news. "That's unfortunate. He was a good man."

The woman brings her hands together and scratches her wrist. "Gunther, as I recall, is out on a field mission. However, since there is a small chance you truly are the one known as 'Hero,' then I will escort you to the king. You should consider yourself fortunate since most others would spit on you, given a chance. I consider myself a pragmatist."

Delightful. "If you don't mind me asking, since I've been gone for a little while, did anything change? Or rather, I know a lot has changed, but I don't know *what* exactly. I've even heard rumors that the 'King' banished me."

The woman turns to one of the guards and nods, and he quickly hustles away, before she turns back to me. "I really shouldn't be telling you this, nor should I have to, but things are working out quite poorly for humanity. Assuming you are 'Hero,' and I still have no proof for that claim, you left us in quite the mess. The so-called Clone War devastated the palace and took quite some time to clean up. After that, several demons gathered together and rose up to try and assassinate the king, but he managed to survive. Naturally, it was Gold Battalion Leader Saul who stopped the insurrection."

Several thoughts occur to me. "Why would you say that the palace was devastated? I repaired the damage with my magic after the fight."

She gives me a long stare. "I wasn't working in the palace, so I wouldn't know. Based on the condition of the rest of the city, however, I assume your claim is false."

Cassiel clutches Howard a little tighter. "We did leave rather abruptly. I thought it was odd you wanted to get out of Hero City so quickly, Hero."

Now I'm really confused. "That- that's not right at all! I repaired the damage! Furthermore, the rest of the city wasn't even affected! I battled Hope and limited the scope of the battle to the Palace only, then I absorbed him after the battle. I didn't seriously hallucinate all of that, did I?"

Samantha's expression is uncomfortable. "Well, your memory is certainly a little spotty..."

"To say the least," Cassiel says, finishing Samantha's thought for her.

I don't know what to think. The story they're feeding me is different from the one I remember. It's inaccurate. Or is it? I've been having those nightmares, lately. There were the things I predicted that would happen before they did... the missing statues in the room I found Hoarhiim, that memory of Gressil being killed by Cassiel. It can't all just be a bunch of elaborate coincidences. I don't even drink or do drugs!

Before I can pry for more information, several armored men walk up from our right side, and the blonde woman nods at them. "Escort these four to see the king. Keep an eye on the large one, he looks suspicious." She turns back to me. "I'm sure the king will be delighted to say hello, but don't be surprised if he's a little cranky."

I merely nod at her, a feeling of disorientation in my mind. "Yeah... thanks. I'll do that."

The armored soldiers surround us and hug their guns to their chests to look intimidating, but not a single one in our group is impressed. I ignore them, and as we head through the gate,

Cassiel nudges me. "You doing okay? I'm surprised you forgot what happened."

"I didn't forget." I keep my voice calm. "Something's going on. It's like I'm in the right place, but things are off. They aren't correct. I know I absorbed Hope, then repaired the palace. That isn't a figment of my imagination."

Cassiel raises an eyebrow. "You absorbed him? You said you killed him, and that you 'wanted to make sure it hurt.'"

"I said that?" My confusion is reaching panic-inducing levels. "That can't be right. It can't!"

The front of the palace looms large before me. It looks the same as I remember, identical to how I repaired it, even. The gargoyle statues on the corners, along with the flat top give it a feel to something like a modern art museum, but at the same time, the regalia of the people walking around gives it a sensation of belonging to royalty. Even the gaudy gold chandeliers as we step inside aren't out of place.

The more we walk, the uneasy I feel. The palace is the same, the city looks basically the same, but the events leading up to now are different. If my memory was faulty, would I know? Am I secretly schizophrenic?

Doorways into other rooms slip past as the four of us, along with our half-dozen guards march down the hallway toward the throne room at the end. "Cass. Am I different, compared to how I was before? That is, before we left Hero City. Do you remember?"

She shrugs. "You seem the same as ever."

Somehow, that isn't reassuring. *Cassiel* doesn't seem the same. She was somewhat timid up until the day I started having those strange nightmares. She's much less shy than before, and what about Samantha? Would she really kill Gressil to protect an angel? Eh, that sounds accurate enough. I can see that making sense. I knew Cassiel better than I did Samantha, after all.

How strange. I keep thinking about them in the past tense, as if they aren't the same girls I know and love. The mind is a weird thing...

The throne room door looms ahead. One of the soldiers jogs ahead of us and speaks to a man at the front. The older man, with his white uniform, long white hair, and long white beard, looks like something of a Chinese guru. His skin is in exceptional condition though and makes him look much younger than he actually is. He nods to the soldier before leisurely strolling up to us. It barely takes him a second to evaluate me. "Yes, you are certainly 'Hero.' It has been a while since I worked with one of your clones. I am the king's Vizier, Hui Ling. Why have you returned?"

I guess he is a Chinese guru. His question strikes me more as an interrogative question than a bit of friendly catching up, so I play it safe. "I've heard humanity isn't holding up against the demons. I wanted to speak with King Cody- err, rather, King..." I pause as I search for his name. Glancing back, I shoot a look at Samantha, but she shakes her head. *She's already forgotten!*

Cassiel hacks into her fist. "Elshard."

That was it. I turn back to Hui Ling, a look of embarrassment on my face. "...King Elshard. Right. Anyway, I wanted to speak to him and see if I can help."

"How noble of you." Hui's expression doesn't change. "You are in luck. The king is relaxing in the courtyard, and has concluded with his other visitors. Please follow me and I will take you there."

Oh don't bother, I'll just teleport there and save you the trouble, I think to myself. That would be rude though, so I don't. Still, I want to.

It only takes a few minutes for the four of us to follow after the old man to the courtyard. He dismissed our soldier escorts already, apparently feeling they weren't necessary. I finally spot Cody sitting on a bench, poking a stick into a lily pad floating on a pond aimlessly. A fly buzzes around him, but he ignores it.

What immediately catches my eye though, is Cody's face. A disgusting patch of brown flesh rests on his right side, crawling from his hairline down his face and to his chin. A burn mark, it appears, as if his face were thrust into a roaring fire. The entire right side of his face is a mass of mottled flesh, and what can only be described as deep claw marks line the other side. His brown hair has grown out substantially, and he has it pulled down to try and hide the scars, but it does a pitiful job of that.

As we approach, Cody's eyes slowly raise until he's looking right at me. "You."

It's a single word, and the tone is empty of emotion, but at the same time, I sense an unthinkable amount of anger put into the 'greeting.'

"Uh... hi." I feel suddenly awkward, as the man I crowned king after he helped me retake the palace from King Adams stares at me intensely. He doesn't blink and merely gazes into my eyes, as if trying to send a silent message to me.

Hui Ling crosses his arms in front of himself, tucking his hands into the folds on his long sleeves. "My King, as you have already discerned, this is the man known as Hero. I thought it impolite to refuse his audience. However, I can send him away if you-"

"Leave us." Cody cuts off his Vizier, then slowly stands up. His balance is shaky, and his knees quake for a split second before he shudders to his full height.

"As you wish." Hui Ling bows and strolls off, leaving the four of us with his king.

'King Elshard', as he calls himself now, rubs his palms together. "Back so soon? Didn't cause enough damage the first time?" His voice is ragged and hoarse, like he's been swallowing thumbtacks, or as if he has the world's worst cold.

"I don't know what's going on. When I left Hero City, I repaired everything back to new and instated you as king. Now the past seems to have changed, and I left the place in tatter. I sincerely want to apologize if I did such a thing."

He ignores my apology. "'If,' you say? You didn't just leave the city you 'saved' from your other self in shambles, it was devastated. We had to spend a valuable week's worth of military-grade replication just to rebuild from the rubble. It left us weakened, especially when your pet demons betrayed us." Cody gnashes his teeth together. "And now you have the gall to return and spin a half-baked lie, saying you actually fixed the city? My memory must be faulty, *Hero*. I don't remember anything of the sort."

His anger is understandable, given his version of events. The problem is that his memories don't mesh with mine. He might as well be accusing a different person entirely.

"I'm sorry. I don't know what came over me. I remember feeling awful about-" I shoot a glance at Cassiel before looking back, "-about killing my clone. It must have, uh, filled me with guilt. I just, kinda, had to leave. I'm back now though, and I'm ready to solve the problems facing the city."

"How nice of you to come back. And now we all join hands and spin in a circle singing a song, right?" Cody tosses his hands in the air. "Oh, and my face thanks you for your parting gift. You left us with monsters in our midst, and they nearly killed me. Was that an accident too? Are you a backstabber, or just incompetent?"

His words sting, but I don't let them affect me. After all, it wasn't me who did those things, it was someone else. Better to apologize profusely and move forward from here out. "Demons attacked you, right? Any idea who they were?"

The king sighs, annoyed that I'd have the nerve to ask him such a question, but he answers anyway. "All demons look the same to me. However, one of them, the leader, was your personal servant. Beelzebub, or whatever his name was. He orchestrated the whole thing, hit me with a blast of fire when I wasn't looking."

Beelzebub? He does hate humans, but I strictly ordered him not to hurt them, and he can't disobey my orders. "Where is he now? Did you kill him?"

"Of course not! I'm not a savage like those animals! I sent him and all the other demons lurking among humanity to the work camps. He can toil and chip at rocks all day. It's a worse punishment than death!"

Samantha shifts uncomfortably. I can tell she wants to speak her mind, but she's keeping quiet for my sake.

Questions enter my mind and leave at a frantic rate. "You were attacked by a few demons, and you punished all of them by putting them in work camps. Don't you think that was a bit extreme? Just because there are a few rotten apples doesn't mean you should treat all of them as criminals."

Rage fills Cody's aura. "Of course they are! All demons are the same! They tear our men to shreds on the battlefield, then try to slit our throats after we extend them a modicum of kindness! They eat the flesh of humans and seek our total destruction! If there is one thing I know about demons, it's that they are all filthy, mangy dogs! I'll put them all down like the rabid animals they are!"

A noise to my side makes me turn and realize tears are filling Samantha's eyes. "Cody... how could you say that? We worked together. We fought the Grez together! How could you forget the experiences we shared, and lump me in with them?!" She pounds on her chest angrily. "We aren't all monsters! Many good demons have no quarrel with humans! You've punished friends of mine for acts of violence they had nothing to do with! Don't you see that's wrong?!"

Cody's angered expression lessens as he gazes at her slowly, squinting a little bit. "You're a demon?" He quickly turns to me. "You brought a demon here? To my palace?! It seems you are in league with the monsters after all!"

I don't get a chance to respond. Samantha lunges forward and slaps the king lightly, a term I use to indicate a force not quite strong enough to dent a plank of wood. It still sends Cody sprawling to the side as he loses his balance and tumbles to the ground, hitting his head on the soft dirt.

Samantha's eyes, still filled with tears, hold an additional layer of rage. "You bastard! There's only one monster here, and it isn't me! You wouldn't be anything if it weren't for Hero! He saved your life and all of humanity! You owe him everything, and you owe me at least a shred of respect for the time we spent together! If I have to hit you again, I'll knock your goddamned head off!"

It takes several moments before Cody can even form a coherent response. She walloped him so hard the blow nearly knocked him out. "Wha...?"

Slowly, he reaches for the bench to pull himself up. "You- you hit me."

Samantha's rage is already dissipated. "Yeah. Sure did. It felt good, too."

"A demon struck me."

While he mumbles and mutters to himself, I glance around his inner courtyard. Not a soul in sight, not even a single guard. You'd think a man this paranoid about demons would have some security, in case their king was bitch-slapped by a succubus.

"You deserve it. Asshole." Samantha crosses her arms, and Cody turns to look at her again, as he sits on the bench.

A spark of recognition appears in his eyes. "Samantha? Is that you? You... look different."

Apparently, her strength was unforgettable. She nods. "More clothes. Hero also made my tail invisible. You probably didn't recognize my face because you were always looking at my tits."

Cody nods numbly. "Yeah. Something like- like that." He wrings his hands together in his lap. "Since the attack, nobody has raised even a single objection. Nobody fights me about anything. Maybe that's why..." He trails off.

"Great. You're a masochist. I should have known." Samantha wipes her hand on her clothes, as if trying to remove the impression of his face from her palm. "Do I get at least an apology, or what?"

Cody reaches up and rubs the burned part of his face, where Samantha hit him. "Your slap caused me little pain. All the sensation in my face is gone. I'm still luckier than those who died, but- I can't feel anything but anger anymore. I haven't smiled in forever."

Cassiel fidgets next to me, then finally takes a hesitant step toward the king. "Um, you probably don't remember me either, but I'm the angel the previous king kidnapped. I was really grateful when you took Hero's side, even if you didn't really do much to save me. But um- anyway, I think I owe you something."

Saying that, Cassiel reaches into her bottomless well of energy, and sends a wave of healing magic to Cody's face. Within seconds, as if an invisible swarm of scar-eating parasites was attacking his face all at once, the burn marks begin to vanish, along with the gouges and cuts from those who attacked him. A strange feeling of wonder comes over me as I watch Cassiel work her magic. I could have done so as well with my Wordsmithing, but she didn't hesitate. This man who called her friend a monster just seconds before was worth healing, in her eyes. It wouldn't have even occurred to me for a while.

Cody gently touches his face and a look of awe passes over him. "What did you-" He pauses, suddenly realizing his voice isn't horse anymore. "-do?"

"Take a look." Cassiel gestures to the pond, and he leans over to look into it. His reflection appears, and the look of awe is replaced with a stunned silence.

It takes many long moments before he can speak again. "You... healed me? But why?"

"I've been hurt before, too," Cassiel stammers, as the words bring up painful memories. "When someone scars you, especially in such a brutal way, the wounds are much deeper than the flesh. Because the demons attacked and disfigured you, you projected your anger to all the other demons. It was irrational, stupid, and irresponsible, but I understand why you did it."

She glances away, at his reflection in the pond. "This is just the first step. I've healed your face, but the real damage is still there. Only you can fix it, King Elshard. You have to forgive those who hurt you and try to understand what led them to attack. Not even demons do such things without reasons or motive."

He blinks twice. "Are you saying it was my fault they attacked me? I angered them, so they had to get revenge?"

"No. I don't know what their motives were. Maybe their goals were irrational and hate-filled. Maybe they just wanted to kill you to strike fear into the hearts of humans. My point is that if you seek to understand what led them to attack you, you will be able to forgive them, and, by extension, the other demons you unjustly imprisoned." Cassiel turns to stare at him meaningfully. "And, in that way, you will be able to heal *yourself*. You will always be a shell until you can move on from the trauma."

Her words have an eerie wisdom to them, likely because she has already been there and done that. Cassiel knows what it means to feel hate, and then to let it go. She's a saint, a true angel.

"Wark." Howard breaks up the tender moment by struggling in Cassiel's arms until she sets him down, but he jumps into the pond and starts splashing around. I suppose he misses the feeling of water and swimming since that's what ducks like to do.

The duck quacking makes the fog in Cody's head vanish as he stares at the animal silently for a few moments. "I was wrong. I've hurt so many. I punished those who didn't deserve it."

He looks at Samantha. "I hurt you, too, with words sharper than a blade. I'm sorry."

Samantha nods. "I forgive you. Or rather, I will, once you undo the damage that's been done. Release the other demons at once. In the meantime, Hero is going to figure out how to stop the advance of the First Emperor."

Cody's mouth hangs slightly open. "First Emperor? What do you mean? I thought he was in hiding, or didn't care about the other demons."

"Same." Samantha leans against me and yawns. "He's a reclusive one. However, a demon 'friend' of mine confirmed the First is behind the recent attacks. With his power, he's sure to tear through the human ranks."

Cody's face whitens. "You're kidding. That- that's why so many demon attacks have devastated our ranks! They suddenly tripled in power, speed, and ferocity! Even anti-energy has a lesser effect on them than it did before! It's unreal how much more powerful they've become."

My cute succubus shrugs. "I don't know much about the First's powers or abilities. Well, I don't know anything, in fact. I'm never around when fun stuff happens, so I miss out."

"You know the First?" The king frowns. "I know you're a demon, but that seems a little..."

Cassiel coughs. "Don't be alarmed, but Samantha is actually the Second Emperor of the demons, Belial." She leans past me and pokes Sam in the arm. "She's a nice emperor though, not a mean one. Understand?"

"Uhh... huh..." He's unconvinced. "Whose side are you on again?"

"Mine," I answer for her. "And I'm on no-one's side. I just want to put an end to this war."

Cassiel nods, as she brushes a strand of hair from her face. "The cycle of violence must be broken, King Elshard. That won't happen until both sides let go of their hate and ancient rivalries. This includes you, as well as the demons."

Finally, King Cody understands. "Thank you. If you had only been here sooner, so much damage could have been prevented. I- I will have my troops release the demons from the work camps at once."

"I'll go there and speak with them," Samantha says. "As the Second Emperor, I hold much sway with members of my kind. I will do my best to smooth over the divisions. They've only been in the work camps for a few weeks, right?"

"Correct." Cody stands up, though he's still a bit wobbly from Samantha's slap. "Perhaps they will forgive me."

"If they won't, I'll *make* them." Samantha punches her palm suddenly, and her eager grin makes the hair on the back of my neck stand up.

"Don't," Cody says, as he shakes his head. "You can come with me, but no violence. The angel is correct. There has been enough violence."

A pattering sound behind me makes me glance back. The Vizier from earlier is breathlessly walking toward us.

"King Elshard! The demons! They've launched an assault on-" He pauses once he spots the king's face. "My liege? Is that really you?"

Cody nods. "Aye. The woman here is a friend of mine. She healed me. Let's not worry about that, though. The attack- where is it located?"

Hui Ling bows apologetically. "One of our outposts, sire. The demons number five thousand strong. Our men will be overrun by day's end if they don't get any reinforcements."

"Understood," Cody says, as he turns to me. "Hero, since you are back, we could use your military might. Can you assist us?"

Uneasiness appears in my belly. "Yeah. I'll get on it."

Samantha pulls away from me. "I'm going to the work camps. You and Cassiel can go by yourselves."

"We'll do that," Cassiel says, answering for me. "Maybe I can help the wounded."

The king nods soberly. "If there's one thing you can certainly do, it's that."

Part 446c: Prelude Of Light

"Hey! Ylvusk! Old buddy, old pal!"

A rumbling of agony, like that of a broodmother accidentally birthing too many spawn at once, blasts in my gut. Anytime Tvoorik comes running up to me with this much excitement on his face; I can tell it's going to be a *stupid* conversation.

" *Hello*, Tvoorik. What is it this time?" Hopefully, the annoyance in my voice isn't too noticeable.

Gently, I rub my assassin knife across my finger to test its sharpness as Tvoorik giddily jogs over to me. Well, I say 'giddily,' but only I could tell since I know him so well. It would be impossible to spot emotion on a shadow-walker's face if I wasn't already one. We look so scary to the uninitiated.

The lovable goof slows to a stop in front of me, a pained expression visible. "Whaddya mean 'this time'? You don't even know what I'm gonna say!"

"I'd bet five human souls it's some stupid theory about how we're all slaves to the demon emperors and part of a genocidal plot to have the lower ranks exterminated. It's always the same thing with you." I point my blade up one of the hallways. "Now's not a good time anyway. They're sending my group to assist the attack on one of the human outposts. We're going to clean up today, maybe even earn a mutation from the First."

Tvoorik waves his hand nonchalantly at me. "Pff, that stuff doesn't matter! They'll keep feeding you promises, maybe a tiny boost here and there to keep you chomping at the bit, but it never amounts to anything good! Once you know too much, you can't ever get the juicy mutations, like Oracle!" He pokes my arm, as if he's trying to get my attention, though I'm looking right at him. "Anyway, you're not gonna believe what I found out!"

Oh devils, here it comes. "What is it this time? What conspiracy have you uncovered that would have you hopping up and down like you've been on the no-blood diet for a month?"

Tvoorik blasts a toothy grin at me. "I finally have proof that this whole war is a sham! You know about the Volgrim, right?"

"Uh huh. Aliens. They pull the strings. You once theorized they existed because we weren't allowed to talk about them, even though we are. What about them?"

Tvoorik nods violently. "Yeah! Yeah! They don't exist. They're made up!"

Seven Hells. Even this is a new low for him. "And what proof do you have for that absurd claim?"

My 'friend' thumbs his chin. "It all adds up! Satan faked his death; then he invented these supposed aliens to keep us all distracted from his insidious agenda!"

I try my hardest not to facepalm. "But what proof do you have they don't exist?"

He snickers. "Have you ever seen a Volgrim in person?"

"No. Diablo has, though."

"He's a demon emperor! Of course he's in on the lie!"

"Right." My tongue snakes out and wets my lips. *I could really go for a nice bite of tenderized female human. Maybe the left arm.* "So, what, only the demon emperors have seen the Volgrim in person, and thusly that means they don't exist? What would lying about their existence prove? If they wanted to steal energy from humans and kill off the weaker members of demon society, they'd hardly have to resort to such a silly lie."

Tvoorik shakes his head hard enough to send droplets of sweat flying. "No no, you don't get it! They destroyed that planet! The demon emperors said a human did that, but humans can't use magic! Then they created the Volgrim so they'd have a scapegoat for when things get tough for the rest of us! They could say 'it's not our fault you have to give up a few essential liberties, blame the Volgrim!' and sheep like you would believe them!"

"Friend, you're babbling. Nothing you just said connects in the slightest. I can't even see the tentative strings that might link from one thing to another. I think you're going off the deep end."

He scoffs at me. "Cheh, you just can't understand my genius. It's taken decades, even millennia of research to learn all the secrets I know. My investigations have uncovered things that would blow your mind."

"Like what?"

My simple question makes him pause for a few seconds. I can easily see the gears turning in his mind as he tries to think of something. "Diablo is actually a female."

"You can't be serious."

"Bael is afraid of spiders."

"Are you even trying?"

"The Volgrim don't exist."

I've had enough. "You said that earlier! I'll bet that if nobody had ever told you about Volgrim, you'd think they did exist just because 'the powers' wouldn't tell you. You just want to believe the opposite of whatever conventional knowledge says!"

A voice behind me makes me jump in my skin. "That is an accurate assessment." Smealum, the Eldest Animus, stops just to my side and nods at us. "You two need to get going. We need all the help we can get taking those fleshbags down."

"Eldest Animus." I bow my head respectfully to him, but he waves me down.

"None of that, please. Let us start the assault. You're two very talented shadow-walkers, so we'll need you for a stealth mission."

Tvoorik is unconvinced. "Sending us to the frontlines to die, huh? It's because I know too much, isn't it?"

Smealum sighs. "It's not that, you crazy kook. The mission is to assassinate King Elshard, and it's essential we take him down. With him gone, the human power structure will collapse, and victory will be swift."

A spark of eagerness appears in Tvoorik's eye. "Ooh, so we have a special mission? What do we get if we succeed?"

A shrug. "Maybe you can be an Oracle. This assassination will seal the humans back in their cages for good, short of us also having to exterminate the Hero. You'll deserve a reward if you pull it off."

Tvoorik's enthusiasm vanishes instantly. "A suicide mission, is it? You wouldn't offer me the ability to know everything unless you were certain I'd fail. Hm, yes, that must be it."

"You're way too paranoid," Smealum says, as he shakes his head and stomps away. "I'll be at the rendezvous point. Diablo will deliver your orders personally."

Once Smealum is out of earshot, Tvoorik snickers. "It's because I know about the Volgrim. Or rather, the lack of Volgrim existing. They want to silence me. I bet Satan's behind this."

I grab him by the arm and start hauling him after me. "Save it for later. I don't need you exhausting me with your conspiracies before the mission's even started."

* * *

"Beelzebub?" A voice speaks from behind me, one belonging to a female. Women shouldn't be on this side of the camps, so I can only assume she's one of the human soldiers.

When I turn around, I'm surprised to see a face that most learned demons would instantly recognize. It takes me a few seconds to hide my surprise. "Lady Belial? The Second Emperor?"

Have the humans put you in the camps as well?"

A flicker of embarrassment surges through me as I glance at the pickaxe in my hand. My body is covered in sweat and grime, and my hands are stained black from the 'coal' these humans have us mine. What use are disgusting black rocks anyway? Digging them out of the ground is a waste of time and accomplishes nothing. Humans are such wasteful, disgusting creatures.

Belial squints to see me in the low light. "Do you know the human named 'Hero'?"

My body stiffens of its own accord. "I am... familiar with the name."

A man steps out from behind the Second Emperor. *The camp supervisor*. He has a look of trepidation on his face. "B-by the orders of King Elshard, all demons in the work camps are to be released at once. Your imprisonment was due to unfounded f-fears..."

He pauses, as if unsure he should even be saying the words. A letter in his hand, with a wax seal bearing the mark of the King, is unmistakable, even in this low light.

The Second Emperor coughs. "Ahem. Continue."

He nods and narrows his eyes as he reads the letter. "D-due to unfounded fears about the dangers of demons unrelated to the attempted assassination of King Elshard, all demons are being set free and given a small payment for their unjust imprisonment and forced labor."

The pickaxe falls from my hands a moment later as the sweet, delightful news reaches my ears. No longer will I have to follow the orders of *humans*. No longer will I be forced to perform menial, degrading work belying my perfection. I can wash my hands, clean my face, and stop living like a savage. What absolute *hell* these last few weeks have been.

It takes me a moment to compose myself, for I am on the verge of tears. "Thank you, Emperor Belial. You have saved me."

"Eh, it wasn't me. You can thank Hero." She pokes her nose inquisitively. "What's that awful smell?"

The camp supervisor flinches. "Sulfur, ma'am. There's a large deposit buried deeper in the mines."

"Never heard of it." To my surprise, the Second Emperor slides up beside me and loops her arm through mine. "Those rags don't look very good on you. I think you'd look a lot better in a suit. Black would go well with your personality."

The thought of wearing my suit again sends shivers of anticipation down my spine. "Indeed! That sounds wonderful!"

We begin walking up and out of the mine, and many demons, far uglier than I, and far less noble, stare in awe as the Second Emperor stands by my side, looping her arm through mine. Indeed, they must be in awe of my perfect looks, and the powerful female at my side. In all my life, I never thought I would be so honored.

"Beelzebub, the human named Hero, he was the one who ordered the king to set you free." The Second Emperor says this nonchalantly, though the name of the human who imprisoned me fills me with anxiety.

"That is... *kind* of him to do so," I say, picking my words carefully. "I suppose I owe him gratitude, despite the fact he left the demons and myself with the savages. I shall be sure to grovel at his feet when I see him next." My sarcasm is impossible to contain when it comes to the human who shamed me.

"Oh, *Beelzy*," Belial says, as she pulls slightly away and puffs out her lip. "Now, that's no way to talk about the man who set you free! He was in a rush to leave Hero City, and he certainly didn't know a few miscreants would try to murder the human king, nor could he have anticipated King Whatshisname's sentencing of all demons to work camps! Besides, you were only there for a few weeks! Surely you're not a broken demon now that you've had to do some manual labor?"

Her words wound me. "That isn't fair, Emperor Belial. It wasn't just manual labor; it was at the hands of *humans*. I despise them. They're worthless, pathetic little weaklings with zero magical potential. If it weren't for their confounded machines, they wouldn't stand a chance against the might of Satan's Armies."

A blast of sunlight strikes my face and makes me wince, as we step out of the mines into the heat of the midday sun. Belial, however, barely notices the light's intensity. "I've had time to spend with the humans, and I understand a little about their technology. Perhaps you should fool around with their devices a little more! Then you won't feel so alienated by their presence!"

Her cheerful demeanor, for some reason, makes me feel more anxious than usual. "Second Emperor, forgive me for being so blunt. If I may ask, have you grown to *like* the humans? If so, you do understand they are the mortal enemy of demon-kind, right?"

She pulls away from my arm as we stride into a ground of demons packing up their belongings from their work tents. "For a demon born long after Satan's death and the conclusion of the Energy Wars, you're very old-fashioned, *Beelzy*." I cringe internally every time she utters that wretched moniker. "Just because humans sustain demonkind doesn't mean we can't figure out some way to co-exist. I mean, Hero is my lover, and we're doing just fine together!"

Every cell in my body vomits simultaneously. "Y-you're having relations with a human?!" I take a step away from her as waves of disgust wash over me. "Not just any human, but *that one*?! Hero? The one who has killed thousands of demons with his own two hands? That's a betrayal of our people!"

Belial is unfazed by my anger and disgust. She waves a hand at me and smirks. "As I said, you're old-fashioned. He acted in self-defense. Since I've been with him, I've made sure he hasn't harmed a single demon!" She pauses as a look of concern appears. "Well, come to think of it, I did kill Gressil... but I had a good reason for that."

I'm beginning to feel numb to the jokes she utters. "You killed... Gressil? The Eternal Guard? Why?"

"It's complicated," she says, turning away from the tents. "Say, Beelzebub, you never met Satan, did you?"

"Hmm? Of course not. I was spawned long after his death. Why do you ask?"

She gestures for me to follow toward the portals that lead off-world. "I've been thinking about him lately, in secret. Hero doesn't know this, but I long for Satan to return."

Ah, there's yet a chance for her redemption. A small insect buzzes past my face and lands on a flower nearby, but I pay it little heed. "You still crave the most powerful demon, then? Understandable. The hero is a rotting carcass compared to the mighty stallion that Satan represents for you."

Belial shakes her head slowly. "It's not that. It's just- when I think about him, I miss the company he gave me as a fellow demon. At the same time, we were never very close. Our interests barely aligned. All he ever talked about was war, revenge, killing the angels, wiping out the humans, backstabbing the Volgrim. He was always so bitter and angry, but Hero isn't like that. He's caring, thinks about me and what I like, treats me well, and looks out for others before himself."

I eye her suspiciously. "Where are you going with this?"

A shrug in response. "I just want to see Satan one more time. I want to ask him whether he ever really loved or cared about me. I thought about him all the time, but he barely paid me any mind. It was his greed and his desire to be all-powerful that killed him, in the end."

Slowly, I nod along. "I see, now. What you really mean is that you are finally happy. You have someone who cares about you..." *Even if he is a filthy human*, my inner self says silently.

"Yes! That's exactly it." She beams a sweet smile at me as we approach the portal back to Hero City's portal room. "I do wish you would open up your heart to him. Hero doesn't hate you

at all, Beelzebub. In fact, you were the first demon he mentioned when he heard all the demons in Hero City had been imprisoned!"

"Is that so?" I keep my tone neutral as the work camp supervisor silently breaks away to hand the paper to the portal guardsmen. "Where is Hero now?"

"He's going with Cassiel to fight a bunch of demons."

It's only now that I realize the Second Emperor is a total dullard. "And you let him go?! Demons are going to die!"

She shakes her head, and her face becomes deadly serious. "There's nothing to worry about, Beelzebub. Cassiel won't let him hurt anyone. She cares more about peace than any other person I've ever met."

Belial's eyes seem to look past me. "Yes... if anyone can put an end to the war, for good, it's Cassiel. She is the purest soul I've ever known."

* * *

"Non-lethal force only. That's all I'll allow!" Cassiel sticks her tongue out at me. "If you kill even one demon, I'll never forgive you, and neither will Samantha!"

"Wark!" Howard quacks in her arms, as if to emphasize her point.

I shoot a glance up at Ionis. Now that the King knows Ionis is a death robot, he can shed all that disgusting melted skin. "You're not going to kill any demons, right?"

Ionis's eye pivots to look at me. *THIS SENTINEL UNIT HAS NOT BEEN ORDERED BY THE COMMANDER UNIT TO ENGAGE IN COMBAT AGAINST THE DEMON-TYPE ORGANICS. THIS SENTINEL UNIT WILL BE ON STANDBY UNLESS THE ANGEL-TYPE ORGANIC'S LIFE IS IN DANGER.*

Slowly, I blink at him. "Right... the duck... well, as long as you stay out of the way, I'll do what I can."

The four of us step through the portal and right onto the frontlines. Immediately, carnage is everywhere. The sound of energy cannons firing, demons and humans alike screaming in pain, talons raking the Labyrinth walls, all of these greet my ears like a cacophony of chaos. Cassiel and I both flinch as we look around. The massive open area has been carved out of the Labyrinth, with fortifications set up here and there, energy cannons aimed down corridors the demons would have to come through.

The giant open room doesn't have a lot going on inside, as all the action is happening down the dozen hallways feeding into the room. King Cody blanches as he looks around. "They're coming from every route! Hero, can't you do something?"

I can practically hear Cassiel yelling 'NON-LETHAL!' in my mind. "I'm on it. **Teleport!** "

I leave the others behind and jump to the loudest corridor. In the distance, I hear a man scream in pain as his life is ended by a single, brutal attack. A blast of fire lights up the distance, and a dozen other men and women blast the demon who attacked their comrade. Moving deftly, I use my superhuman speed and agility, given to me by the archangels, to leap from wall to wall and even to adhere to the ceiling as I race toward the battle. I quickly spot several humans in badly damaged power armor fighting demons with sword-like arm appendages. The demons dodge attacks with speed not unlike my own, cutting down one woman who makes a single wrong move.

" **Sleep!** " I speak my word magic, and a blast of energy surges out, making every combatant suddenly stagger to and fro, before flopping over on the ground a second later. Dashing over, I cradle the woman who was just hit by one of the demons. " **Heal.** "

The huge gash in her stomach heals up within a couple of seconds, and her hand jerks up to clutch the phantom wound. The healing process from my magic can often be as painful as the initial wound.

Up ahead, the hallways branches into a much bigger room, where dozens, if not hundreds more humans and demons are clashing. " **Teleport.** " I leave the woman behind and jump to the others, using my Wordsmithing rapidly in succession. " **Sleep! Nap! Bedtime!** "

Like dominoes toppling each other over, demon and human alike stagger forward, falling over awkwardly, often right in the middle of attacking. One human with a vibrosword nearly falls on top of his weapon, impaling himself, but I pop over to him and shove him forcefully out of the way before healing any of the injured humans or demons. My energy has barely even dropped!

" **Scan.** " A pulse shoots from my body in a 360-degree sphere, illuminating the Labyrinth and the corridors around me. Red spots show heat signatures from human and demons alike, so I begin systematically jumping from the biggest hotspots to the smallest, but it's on the sixth one that surprises me. The humans and demons are already asleep! Cassiel stands amidst a field of sleeping bodies and smiles radiantly at me. "I'm helping!"

"You put everyone to sleep?"

"Yup!" She flaps her wings and leapfrogs halfway across the room to one woman who is bleeding profusely, then gently heals her wounds. "Samantha should have been here. She has healing magic too, you know. Go on and save more lives!"

I nod and start to leave, only to find that a tremendous magical presence has arrived in the room.

Diablo, Third Emperor of the demons, and beside him is Bael, the Fourth Emperor. Both of them casually stroll inside and glance around at the bodies.

Bael clutches the chain to a giant flail wrapped around his body. "What is the meaning of this?! You're putting our demons to sleep!"

"Same as I'm going to do to you," I say simply. Reaching my hand out, I Wordsmith again. "**Sleep!**"

Bael and Diablo's eyes flutter shut, but a moment later they surge back open, and Bael gnashes his teeth. "Your tricks won't work, Hero! We're protected by the First Emperor's magic!"

Well, that's unfortunate. "You don't have to fight us. I'm trying to end the war peacefully."

Diablo, for a moment, almost looks hopeful, but the look vanishes. "Never trust a human. I learned that lesson a long time ago. If you wish to end a war, blood must be spilled. There is no easy way out."

Cassiel finishes healing the injured human woman and leaps to her feet. "You're wrong! Peace is attainable! If you just keep fighting, more will die! It will never end!"

The Third's gaze narrows. "Big words, coming from an angel. The angels created the demons to serve their whims. When we became a little too out of control, you tried to purge us, but it was too late. We had already discovered the secret of mutation. Now you are the last angel left. Killed by your own slaves; fancy that."

Cassiel is taken aback. "A-angels didn't do that... you're lying..."

"I'm not. I'll never trust a human, and especially not an angel."

Bael uncoils the flail from his body and lets the massive spiked club drop to the ground. Its immense weight leaves a small crater in the ground when it hits. "Talk is cheap! I'll crush the both of you!"

Cassiel looks at me nervously, and I send her a look that says '*About that no-killing rule...*'

Part 447c: Usurper

"Come at me, human! Hold nothing back!" Bael, the demon with the giant flail, leaps to the side with a speed that surprises me, and tosses his spiked ball in my direction. Using the agility that the gods have given me, I perform the splits on the ground, ducking under the ball and letting it smash harmlessly into a wall to my rear.

Unfortunately for Bael, this area is the perfect size for me. Neither too large nor too small, it gives me ample room to use my quickness to its fullest. Digging the edges of my toes into the ground, I leap headfirst at the lumbering demon, grabbing his two bull-like horns and vaulting behind him, then kicking off his back to send him sprawling face-first in the dirt. A second later, I impact the wall behind where he had just been standing, and thrust myself off it to jump at him again.

" **Freeze!** " With a single word, I project my wordsmithing at his feet and hands, and a small ice age grabs his kneeling body and holds him to the ground. My hand lances forward, aiming directly for his heart. Just before impact, the ice wrapped around his hands and legs vanishes, and his fist swings around in midair, smashing me right in the face.

It takes a few seconds for me to shake my head as the pain comes rolling in. I somehow ended up embedded a couple inches in the wall. My whole body aches.

"You thought you could just use Wordsmithing to cheat, huh? This is a match between barbarians, Hero! Real men use their fists when they fight, not their lips!" Bael cackles and yanks his flail back to himself. I barely dive out of the way as the giant ball of death impacts where I was just sitting. Scrambling to my feet, I feel blood trickle down my nose.

"Talk about an ice-breaker. How'd you escape so quickly?"

One eye follows the flail's movements as Bael lunges it at me again, and the other keeps an eye on his face to follow his gaze. "The First Emperor has granted all of demonkind unprecedented power! Breaking free of your word magic is a trivial thing for one as powerful as he."

This time, when the flail lunges for me, I try a different word. " **Reflect!** " The chained mace impacts an invisible wall and bounces back at Bael, and despite the unexpected move, Bael surprises me by lunging his hand out and catching the flail with one hand. If it stabs his palm, he doesn't show any sign of pain.

I'm breathing hard already. It's as if there are anvils attached to my legs. The impact against the wall must have hurt me more than I thought, though that wouldn't seem possible under

normal circumstances. The powers of the God-King grant me incredible regenerative abilities. "If the First Emperor is so damn powerful, why stay in hiding? Why wait until humanity is crushing the demons to make a move? Something doesn't add up."

Before Bael can respond, Diablo, standing casually on the opposite side of the room, takes the opportunity. "We do not question the First Emperor's actions or motivations. He has come to aid us now, having saved up his power over the eons. Once we eliminate you, we will push the humans back to the worlds from whence they came and wipe their minds once more of this 'technology' nonsense."

Cassiel stands silently at the furthest corner, watching me duel Bael. She has nothing to say regarding our fight, but in her eyes, I hear her plea. *No killing.*

Well, sorry, princess. This Bael guy is somehow able to nullify some of my Wordsmithing, and trying to hurt him is like punching a mountain to make it cry.

Under my breath, I whisper a word. " **Telekinesis.** "

I don't use mental manipulation much because I'm not very familiar with how it works, but I need an edge here. This time, I violently kick my foot into the ground with enough force to send shards of debris at him. Nothing dangerous, but it makes him shield his face for a split second. Using that instant, I teleport behind him, and when his reflexes make him lunge toward me, I bat his hand away with telekinesis and punch him in the face with all my strength.

A moment later, I'm on my back, wondering what happened. Just like how I reflected his attack earlier, my fist hit an invisible wall and reflected my kinetic energy back at me.

This demon... who is he? It's like he's using my Wordsmithing against me.

Then the pain hits. My wrist is shattered, as if I tried to hammer concrete into dust with my fist. Whatever his reflection did, it must have multiplied the force I used several times over.

When I climb to my feet, Bael snickers. "You're having a tough time there, eh, Hero? In between spurts of agony, you're probably wondering how I keep one-upping you."

Cassiel flutters over to me and touches my shoulder lightly. When she looks down at my right hand, her body stiffens. "The bone is sticking out. Let me heal it."

I gently push her away. "This is between Bael and me, Cass. Whoever this demon is, he has a bone to pick. I have to finish this myself. **Heal.** "

It takes a Herculean effort for me not to chew my lip off as my bones and cells ram back together forcefully, mending the wound. A few seconds later, the only pain that remains is the phantom wounds in my mind, but sometimes those can be worse than physical scars.

Diablo looks impatient. "Bael, quit toying with him. Finish him off, or I'll have to step in. We're running out of time."

Bael whips his head back and snarls. "Why don't you lay offa me?! Try peeling apart the angel while I take on the Hero! This is my fight alone! Have a sense of honor!"

The Third Emperor curls his lip. "I prefer not to hurt females where possible. I'm more respectable than that." He pauses to eye Cassiel up and down. "Still, for the last of your kind, your spiritual energy is unthinkable. In many ways, it's similar to that of the First Emperor's. Don't take my previous statements to mean I don't consider you a threat. I'd simply prefer not to fight a woman, and certainly not to extinguish the life of the final angel."

Cassiel takes a step toward Diablo. "I-I'm not helpless! In fact, I could blast you into another universe if I wanted! Don't look down on me just because I'm a girl!"

"The Second Emperor is a woman. She beat me to a pulp once." Diablo shivers and a look of disgust washes across his face. "I've never been so humiliated."

I flinch as Bael leers toward Diablo. "Hah! Go figure; you got beat by a woman! Just what I expected from our glorious leader! Makes me wonder what the First sees in you."

The two demons growl at each other, and Cassiel shares a confused look with me. We have no idea what these two are bickering about, but it looks like an internal power struggle.

"You choose now of all times to complain about my leadership?! We're in the middle of a battle!" Diablo wrings his hands together as veins bulge from his forehead. "Your idiocy always pisses me off!"

"At least you're angry! You didn't weep for our lost comrades, or explode in rage at their deaths when the humans gutted them!" The flail twitches as Bael turns even more of his attention to the Third Emperor. "I'll bet you were glad they died! You think demons deserve to be slaughtered, because you're a devil-damned pacifist!"

"Pacifist?! How dare you!" Diablo's fist swings out and smashes into the wall at his side as he unleashes a tiny bit of rage on the Labyrinth, forming a small crater under his fist. "I fought alongside Satan in the earliest wars!"

"As did I!" Bael shambles closer to his senior, towering two heads higher than him. Both of them can't be more than a few inches apart. "I've grown tired of your nostalgia. All you ever do is complain and bitch and whine and moan."

Diablo stares up at his taller counterpart. "Are you challenging me?"

Cassiel wants to say something. I can see it in her eyes, but I gently tap her wrist. *Let this play out. A fight between these two could work out for us.*

Barely have I tried to send the thought from me to her when a flurry of movement makes us both jerk back in surprise. Bael hurls his spiked ball at Diablo, and the Third Emperor slaps it aside like a champ. "I guess we're doing this right now?! You worthless subordinate!" With a strength that surprises Cassiel and I, Diablo delivers a brutal palm strike into Bael's chest, sending him flying back into the wall on the opposite side of the room.

"Gah!" Bael coughs, and a small sense of pain ekes into his voice. The demon I could barely hurt before is... injured?

I teleport Cassiel and myself to the opposite side of the room to watch. The battle is still raging on, further behind us, humans versus demons, but as long as the strongest demon commanders can't join the fray, things might work out well. "Cass," I lean in close and whisper in her ear as Bael flings himself at his leader, "Go back to the frontlines and help out. You're strong enough to survive blows from these monsters, let alone the small fry. If you won't fight, you can at least heal the wounded. Let King Cody know what's going on. I have to stay and see what happens."

She fidgets, not wanting to leave my side, but she also hears the wisdom in my words. Finally she grunts. "Okay. Stay safe." With a quick movement, she pecks me on the cheek and darts down the hallway from whence we came. Both Demon Emperors are too busy to notice her leave, but after they're done pounding each other, I'm sure they won't be thrilled about her departure.

"You damned son of a troglodyte!" Bael swings huge, overpowered blows at Diablo, but his commander bats them aside with movements similar to that of martial artists. "Stop dancing around and fight me!"

"I am." Diablo's anger is gone, as he enters a trance-like state. Anticipating each of his opponent's blows, he uses palm deflections, and the occasional magic spell to knock his junior off-balance. Sometimes his foot jerks out and trips the bigger, bulkier demon aside. "You should be aware of something, Bael. It's not that I was beaten by Belial because I am secretly a weakling, it is because she is far more powerful than me. She's cunning, a master manipulator. She hides her strength behind soft words. You, however, are a loud, boisterous oaf. You have almost no magical energy to speak of, and rely entirely on your strength and speed to win. Not to mention that worthless flail."

His calmness unnerves Bael, and myself, though I'm not even a part of the fight. Bael snarls at his senior. "One hit and you're toast! I'll break every-" He stumbles forward, tripping over Diablo's deliberately outstretched foot, and rights himself. "-every bone in your stupid ugly face!"

"You are indeed strong." Diablo stops with the palm strikes and changes his style, clasping his hands together to make a battering ram for a fist. "But brains are what win battles, not military might." Saying this, he slams his double-fist into Bael's gut and knocks the wind out of him. Bael staggers back and wheezes, clasping his fat belly as sweat rolls off his face.

"Y-you-!"

"It's already over. Please stop with the nonsense." Diablo quickly weaves a magic spell with his hands, and Bael's eyes turn white.

"What the- where did everything go?!" Bael claws at his face, and I realize Diablo has blinded him. In the next instant, Diablo leaps forward and delivers a hail of jabs, palm strikes, and punches into Bael's vital organs. The bigger demon swings his arms around futilely to try and block the Third Emperor's savage attack, but it's no use.

Diablo stops, and his lesser flops to the ground, a puddle of sweat and pain. "Hero. Where did your angel girlfriend go?" He doesn't give me a chance to respond. Without warning, he leaps toward me, fist raised.

Forgive me, Cass. I may need to take things further than you'd like.

* * *

"Hold on; I'll heal you." I squeeze the woman's hand as I pour energy into her. The wounds quickly close, but it's too late. Her spirit trail fades, and her eyes lock open as her head lulls to the side. I was seconds late.

"Cassiel!" Samantha waves at me, and I blink back tears. I don't want her to see me cry over a woman I didn't even know.

I fly over to her, still fighting the sickening sensation back. "Sam, where are all the wounded? I have to heal them."

As I land, I spot a familiar handsome demon beside her. Wearing a black suit with a crimson tie, his hair is slicked back, and his entire demeanor is business-like. He bows slightly at me. "Before you ask, I am Lord Beelzebub. The Second Emperor rescued me from the human work camps."

"Oh. Yeah, I think we've met before." I barely pay him any mind.

Samantha nudges me. "The wounded are taken care of. I healed them already, Cass."

"Good to hear. Are you running low on energy?"

She shakes her head. "I'm fine, and I've got plenty more left over. Anyway, those soldiers are going to enter combat and get torn apart again. If I don't do something, the battle is going to

turn into a bloodbath."

Behind me, I hear a scream of pain as a demon is blasted with a hail of anti-energy. "We can't just heal the humans; we have to heal the demons too. And you! You're the Second Emperor! Demand they stand down, and I'll do the same for the humans."

Samantha starts to say something, but from behind her, a man's voice yells out. "Keep fighting! Mow the bastards down! Blast them to smithereens!" I'm shocked to see King Elshard step out from behind some sandbags and flag down a few men. "We have the demoness healing our men and women. Suicide tactics are okay. Make sure the vermin suffer."

"K-King Elshard!" I take a step toward him and stammer out the words. "What are you saying?! I thought you were going to forgive the demons!"

The King quickly nods at me. "I have! I've freed all the demons I wrongfully imprisoned. Those demons were, of course, allies to humanity. You were right in that judging all of them for the actions of a few was the wrong course of action. However, the shit-spitters in the Labyrinth are mongrels in need of being put down. I will destroy them, and kill their Emperors." He blinks at Samantha. "Aside from you, of course. Your loyalty is respect-worthy."

Confusion and anger pass over Samantha's face. "Loyalty?! I am not loyal to humans. I simply agree with the idea of peace. You are not working toward that goal, you're-"

The king cuts her off. "Peace is a farce. If you want peace, you have to earn it. Kill those who are below you! Only once you are among others of your kind can you have that stability the angel seeks."

Beelzebub chuckles, "Kukuku... I agree with you, King Elshard. Your words have a certain wisdom to them."

The king smiles at Beelzebub. "As do yours! You are a praiseworthy demon! I apologize for putting you in the camps, and hope that you will, in time, forgive-"

"Don't patronize me." Beelzebub's lightheartedness vanishes. "I merely agree with the sentiment. Only once humans are dead, rotting in the ground, will demonkind have stability. Humans are the parasites in this ecosystem, not my people."

"Beelze...bub?" Samantha stares at the suited demon, but the king cuts her off.

"You... you! I released you from the camps! You're supposed to be loyal to-" He pauses, as a look of recognition appears in his eyes. "Yes, I remember you now. Beelzebub, the demon inside the palace. You're the one who orchestrated my assassination! You burned and scarred me!"

Beelzebub grins widely. "I most certainly did not. As much as I loathe and detest humans, I am bound to not hurt any of them, as per the orders of the one who sealed me as a puppet.

Hero, to my chagrin, controls me as much as he pleases. Were I to assassinate you, there would be no 'try' to it. Even the two lovely healers behind me wouldn't be able to reassemble your ashes."

Everyone stares at Beelzebub in shock, not least the king. "I-I-I should have you executed right now! Monster!"

"Do as you please. It's not like I can fight back. Prove me right, in front of these girls. Execute a non-combatant. The devil knows you'd love to do it." Beelzebub takes a daring step toward the king. "Go ahead, just a dozen shots from those anti-energy rifles will wipe me out."

The king glances uneasily from Beelzebub to us, realizing the moral quandary he's in. If he murders the demon, he'll be the monster Beelzebub claims he is, but if he doesn't, it will make him look weak.

Before he can make the decision, Samantha steps forward. "Beelzebub, as Second Emperor, I'm ordering you to stand down. You're out of line."

"Am I?!" Beelzebub whirls to face her. "At least I'm here against my will! You've fallen for a filthy, disgusting *human*. The very one who imprisoned my mind! You willingly stand beside those who murder your people!"

Samantha turns away from his gaze. "It's... it's not like that. I'm just- I don't know what to do."

"You're the second most powerful demon in existence! Yet you've ended up a worthless whore, smitten head over heels with the human who will be the end of our species! You've never, not once in your entire life, cared about your fellow demon!" Beelzebub pulls back, a disgusted look on his face. "From where I stand, you might as well already be a human."

Gently, I pull Samantha back. The look of defeat on her face makes me want to punch this stupid suit in the kisser. "Beelzebub, that's enough. We're in the middle of a battle. Please... save this for later."

He throws his hands in the air and stomps off. "Fine. Arguing with women and humans is beneath me anyway."

The king is puzzled. He looks around, wondering how to proceed after that outburst, so I calm him down. "Beelzebub has issues. Let's worry about him later. I'm going to the frontlines to heal the wounded." With a knowing gaze, I eyeball him intently. "That means humans *and* demons. Right, Samantha?"

"Huh? Y-yeah, sure." She nods weakly and tries to hide the guilt in her eyes, but it's evident to everyone present that Beelzebub's little tirade got to her.

King Elshard rubs his hands together. "If I pull my forces back, can the two of you do something to stop the demons? Samantha, as the Second Emperor, perhaps you could..." He trails off, and she nods.

"It's my duty. Lord Beelzebub was right, you know. I can't just let myself go along for the ride when I have the power to stop this war." Samantha pulls herself together and turns back to the mess of hallways. "I just hope the others of my kind are willing to listen. The First may override me."

"It's worth a shot," I say, the words almost a whisper. "Even if you can't make the demons listen to reason, you should try. Jason would be proud of you."

The king nods at us and struts away, but Samantha's knees tremble. "If I stand up as the Second now, then why didn't I sooner? I've always been so weak-willed."

I push the sounds of death in the distance away and hug her gently. "That's not true, Sam. Your will is stronger than you think. Now, come on. People are dying while we mope."

She nods, and together, we head into the Labyrinth.

* * *

Beelzebub enters his chambers in the Palace, where he used to stay before the world turned topsy-turvy and he was cast into the work camps along with his lesser demons. Stepping in front of a mirror, he scowls as he notices an ugly speck of black coal stuck to his face. "A blemish. It's not perfect."

With a flourish of movement, he grabs a dry towel hanging from a nearby rack, plunges it under the tap-water, and scrubs his face viciously.

"Perfect... perfect... perfect..." His teeth grind together loudly enough that were anyone else within a few feet, they could hear the noise. "It must be perfect." When he pulls the towel away, he glares at his hands. No matter how he scrubs them, the blackness of coal won't come off so easily. The ugly filth shrouds his otherwise flawless, radiant red skin.

"They made me toil, and dig, and *sweat*, as if I were an orc, or a beggar forced to earn his keep. Me?! The magnanimous, eminent Beelzebub?!"

As he gazes at his reflection in the mirror, he scowls at the bags under his eyes. "And they had the nerve to look down on me. I could exterminate every human in this city with the movement of one hand. I could burn their disgusting structures to the ground. But really, I can't! This accursed binding prevents me from resisting."

After a few moments, the rage dissipates. "Such is my lot in life. Gifted in every manner, blessed from birth. Sharing air with these creatures is enough to make me--"

An interruption. A soft knocking at the door draws Beelzebub's attention away from his self-pity.

"Who wishes to enter?"

A soft female voice speaks up. "Um. It's m-me, Rosalia."

Ah. That one. "You may enter." Immediately, Beelzebub dries his face with a gout of flame. It wouldn't do, after all, for others to see him in this state.

The door opens, and a small, shy demoness creeps in. Her skin isn't cherry-red like other demons; it's much softer and creamier. *Like a human's*, Beelzebub thinks to himself.

"Master Beelzebub, I heard you enter the palace. Nobody else is here. I thought y-you were going out to the battlefield." Her dull brown robes match perfectly with her unremarkable face and mediocre body. *Her energy levels are pathetic, too.*

Beelzebub steps into his bedroom and leans against a wall casually as if he hasn't a care in the world. "My presence was unnecessary. I can't kill any humans, and I won't harm my brethren. As such, I have retired for the day."

"Oh..." She blushes and glances away. "Um, I wanted to thank you for getting me out of the work camps early. The guards said it would be a week's wait otherwise for processing."

"A trifle. You were a relatively competent underling in the camps. Even living among humans, you know your place is at the bottom."

The girl winces at Beelzebub's unkind words but carefully sits on his bed, making sure not to disturb his perfect bed-cover arrangements. "I... I know. I don't understand much, and I'm not very strong. I'm just useless."

"Correct." The tall demon doesn't bother to assuage her concerns. "In any case, now that I have brought you into the palace, I will expect you to continue serving my needs. I require breakfast at 5:30 every morning, *sharp*. Tardiness won't be tolerated. You will press my suits just after delivering my breakfast, thus getting them ready for me to wear. There is also the drawing of my baths, twice every day, once in the morning, and again later at night. Following this-

She interrupts him. "Sorry, Lord Beelzebub. Um, I already have a list made, sir." She reaches into her pocket and procures a handkerchief, smiling weakly as she shows him the markings on it.

Beelzebub scowls. "Your handwriting is atrocious. Did a blind leper with two fingers teach you the way of the quill?"

Rosalia blushes. "Err, no, sir. I taught myself."

"Poorly." Beelzebub practically spits the word out. "No servant of mine is going to scrawl clumsily with their fist, as if they were Lord Bael. The stupid lunk couldn't write worth a damn if-" Beelzebub pauses, realizing he's letting his emotions get the best of him. "Anyway, the least you could do is aspire to be better than the humans. You're pathetic, and you look enough like them, that one day I might mistake you for one of them."

"Um... I mean, humans aren't that bad, though, are they?" Rosalia winces again as Beelzebub's expression flares to show an inkling of anger. "I m-mean demon society is harsh, and brutal... if you don't catch a break, it's so hard to get any souls to evolve... and there are so many demons, it's almost impossible to rise through the ranks..."

Beelzebub stares at her quietly for a few moments. "Is that why you joined the human society? You thought you would make some friends here? You presumed you might stand out, be someone important? Human society exalts the weak and raises up the poor and downtrodden. They're such soft souls. Which is *precisely* why they must be exterminated."

Beelzebub snaps his fingers, and a few candles light up around the room. Leaning over, he flips a switch to turn off the electric lights in the room. "Just using their technology makes me feel ill."

Rosalia nods along, but she doesn't quite understand what he means. "Don't you think lights activated by a switch are brighter and easier to use? The reason they win against demons is that they build those scary machines... doesn't that make them smart? Maybe even..." She hesitates, seeing a familiar anger in his eyes. "...smarter than... us?"

"They aren't smart! They're stupid apes! Monkeys!" Beelzebub accidentally lets his anger out for the second time, glaring daggers at the girl. "They can make some gears turn and a robot talk! Big deal! I can conjure fire out of midair! Can any human do that?!"

Rosalia doesn't say anything, but Beelzebub can hear her retort floating in the air. *The Hero can...*

"Never mind. Get out of my sight!" Beelzebub spins and walks back into the bathroom. "Starting tomorrow, you are to begin your duties. For today, I wish to be alone."

The door slams behind him, and Rosalia casts her eyes down to the ground. "Yes, mister Beelzebub, sir..."

Part 448c: Sealed

"Why isn't anyone listening?!" Samantha looks at me with panic in her eyes, before turning to another demon running directly at us, a Scyther by the looks of him. "Halt! I am the Second Emperor! Lay down your-"

"Blood! I want blood!!" The crazed demon drools incoherently and slobbers as he raises both of his bladed arms. Samantha, intent on not harming her kind, doesn't resist until the very last second, before lightly slapping him away, though the force nearly kills him as he plows through four other demons, then impacts a wall.

"They're crazed!" Samantha balls up her fists as more humans run past us through the cramped hallway toward the demons, unleashing a hail of anti-energy on the foes. Many of the shots meet their target, but the demons shake the otherwise grievous wounds off as if they were being poked with thumbtacks. The terror on the human's faces as their weapons are relatively ineffective turn to hatred as they continue blasting the red-skinned demons.

"Fucking blood-skins! Eat shit and die!" One human pulls out an energy sword and charges at the nearest scyther, but he's sliced clean in half before I can stop him. I quickly knock the Scyther back with a wave of energy before it jumps at us, but slowing them down won't stop their rampaging.

I turn to Samantha. "Their spiritual energy- it's dark and twisted. Even your spirit trail isn't red, as usual. It's tinged with blackness. Something is polluting the energy of all the demons, and it's also driving the humans into a frenzy!" I quickly glance down at myself to be sure, but whatever's affecting the others isn't affecting me. My trails are pure white, as they always are.

Samantha grits her teeth. "It's the First Emperor. He must be using his colossal power to control the minds of everyone present- or maybe he's boosting the demons and weakening the humans, or- I don't even know."

More humans are smitten down as blasts of electricity surge down the corridor from a pair of spellcasters. I smash them into the ground with a long-range telekinetic attack, which appears to batter them unconscious... for now.

"Sam, who is the First Emperor? You've met him before, right? If we know who he is, maybe we can counter him!"

She shakes her head vehemently. "I must have seen him dozens of times, but after every meeting, my mind went blank. Eventually, I stopped going, since it was pointless talking to someone I couldn't remember. Even Diablo didn't know who he was."

"But you know the First Emperor is a male, right? Think! Surely you must have seen his face. Maybe a fragment of a memory, anything would help us."

A sudden sensation on my foot makes me look down. A man, barely alive, is reaching with all his might toward me. "M-my lady... help- I can't..."

I heal him after a second, realizing his legs have deep slashes in them and he dragged himself all this way. Once the man recovers, he climbs to his feet and wheezes, "I owe you my life." Saying this, he dashes away. More humans continue to rush past us, like meat being thrown into a grinding machine.

Samantha bites her lip. "It's no good. I can't remember anything. Cassiel, you should try putting everyone to sleep. That should buy us time to-"

"Won't work." I cut her off before she can finish. "I managed to put a few to sleep earlier, but they rose to their feet not ten seconds later. Something keeps nullifying my-" I pause, sending a massive wave of energy down the corridor and blasting a hundred more demons backward, and they land in a giant pile, blocking the corridor. They'll have to gather themselves, and that should slow them down a few moments. "-my magic."

Samantha looks at me seriously. "You know, the way Jason's attacks were reflected, and how your magic is being shut down... it's almost like we're facing a Wordsmith." She licks her lips as her haggard gaze meets mine. "And the demons here are fighting together a little *too* uniformly and aggressively. If... If I had to make a guess-"

She's cut off, as a huge explosion echoes from down the corridor toward where the demons are emerging. I'm stunned to see a wall of foam has formed, blocking off the path from whence they came. A man in high-ranking military garb runs up to the platoon of soldiers.

"Fall back! We're using the experimental weapons to seal the hallways! Let's draw the bastards into a choke point!"

Samantha glances at the man, then back to me. "I hope I'm wrong. But- but then again... I also want to be right."

I don't get a chance to ask what she means. Samantha turns away and quickly makes a motion with her hands, sending waves of healing energy toward all the injured men around us. "Let's go, Cass. There are others we need to treat."

Her words are punctuated by distant *booms*, as more of the 'experimental weapons' detonate.

* * *

Grisly sights greet us once we arrive back in the main chamber. Thousands, even tens of thousands of humans mill around in the room, some running, others staggering, as Samantha and I rush to heal as many as we can. I note with interest that at least the First Emperors boost to demons seems to apply to her as well, allowing her energy to reach enough heights that healing hundreds of humans poses little or no problems.

Something catches my eye, while Samantha is off healing the others. A group of men rushes out of one of the hallways, as a *boom* echoes from where they came. The men are quickly, but gently, carrying King Elshard. Several stab wounds run across his body. I detect his spiritual energy, so he isn't dead yet, but he will be soon.

I flap my wings and arrive over where he is, just in time to hear him cough blood. "B-bastard ruby-skinned monsters... the second time- the second time...!"

Healing energy expels from my aura as I heal the wounds. Slowly, color returns to his face as his body regenerates. "King Elshard, what happened?"

Laying on the ground, the king tilts his head toward me. "Ah, winged one. You've saved me a second time. Truly, you are the Divine Mother incarnate."

"It was nothing, King Elshard. I'm just doing what I can. Who attacked you?"

"Shadow-walkers. Two of them." The King pulls himself into a sitting position and heavily breathes as he glances at the hallways. "We tagged the bastards, but they got away. The demons always rely on trickery and deceit to win their battles. 'Target the command structure, and the humans will fall,' I'll bet that's what they're thinking." A somber expression passes over his face. "Where have I gone wrong? Under my rule, humanity has been reduced to panicked children. We can barely hold the demons off, let alone crush them as we were doing before."

I gently pat him on the shoulder, as Samantha trots over to us. "Attacking the demons so viciously, without any regard for diplomacy or any other options, only angered them. As long as violence is the only way you communicate with them, they will progressively increase their military might against you until you eventually fall."

Samantha apparently catches the last bit of the conversation. "Cassiel is correct, King Elshard. You underestimate how grossly outnumbered humanity is. The Labyrinth is enormous, like the hollowed out innards of a star. Demons live in every crack and crevice. The reach of humanity so far can barely be stated as less than one percent of its total area."

A man in heavy armor jogs up to us breathlessly. "My liege! We have sealed all of the tunnels except for the one you requested. The high-density Contanium is holding well against the hordes. It will take them an hour to break through if they sustain their efforts."

"Don't hold back. Keep lining the halls with it. Eventually, they will have to re-route. When they come through the final path, they will meet their end under a hail of gunfire." The King rises to his feet and brushes himself off. "Thank you, blessed angel. While I understand your words of peace, the time is long gone for diplomacy. Perhaps, after this battle..." He trails off and looks toward the final remaining hallway.

I share a glance with Samantha, noticing a look of fear on her face. She grabs my shoulders. "Where is Jason? How will he get back to us?"

The King answers for her. "Aye, we left his hallway unsealed. We wouldn't want our most powerful warrior to be trapped with the mons-" He halts, likely realizing that calling demons 'monsters' in front of their Second Emperor might be a *tad* discourteous. "-trapped with the Third Emperor and his hordes."

Well, at least he can try to be *slightly* civil to a demon, *bless his heart*.

"Samantha, when I left, Diablo was battling Bael. I don't know what happened after that. It's likely that Jason will have to fight one of them afterward, but they'll be weakened."

She curls her lip. "Infighting? Why would Diablo and Bael duel each other now, of all times? They've had their share of differences, but in the midst of an invasion?"

We share a look of concern, until a sentry blows on a horn. "Someone approaches! Ready, men!"

Spinning quickly, I fly up into the air and peer down the hallway leading to where Jason is. Once I see his form emerge from the darkness, a relief fills my very soul. *He made it*.

That sensation vanishes immediately. Diablo, the third Demon Emperor, emerges from behind Jason, holding my lover by the head. Jason's body is battered and broken. He's been hit with so many attacks he can't even twitch a finger, let alone stand. Hanging limply in Diablo's grip, his eyes are swollen shut. No words escape his lips, and his spirit is faint. He must be unconscious, and barely hanging on.

Diablo sighs and tosses Jason forward, letting his body slap into the ground with a sickening *crunch*. As I fly down to where he is, I'm almost knocked to the side as Samantha races past me, moving faster than I thought imaginable. She quickly cradles Jason's body, horror on her face. I land beside her and send healing energy to Jason, even as she glares at Diablo.

"What did you do to him?!"

The Third Emperor shrugs. "Honestly, Belial, I don't remember. He barely put up a fight. His hand-to-hand skills are pathetic. You're not going to get all mopey, are you?" Diablo frowns at her. "You can heal him, you know."

Samantha slowly scrunches her hands together into fists. Her energy begins to change, to blacken, before my very eyes. "You... you hurt... my honey..." Blood trickles down her chin as she gnashes her teeth so hard she bites her tongue.

"Hey, I left him alive. I had to teach him his place." Diablo holds his hands up and glances at all the nervous humans aiming their weapons at him. "It was a fair fight. Mano-a-Mano. Surely you can't hold that against me."

Her entire body shakes, and her eyes blacken as she slowly stands to face the Third. "You're not the only one about to learn his place today."

"C-calm down, Belial. I wanted to talk with you for a few moments, about the- the um... Belial?" As Samantha leaps at his throat, Diablo takes a quick step back. "Oh, fuck."

Part 449c: The Creator

The flowers are in bloom. Finches chirp in the tree above me, and the sound of wind whistles through a nearby forest, soothing my soul. The sun gently warms the land, and a butterfly flutters over my prone body. I reach up and rest my head on my hand, staring at the cloud formations above.

"That one looks like a sword," I mutter to myself. After a few moments, I sigh. "I can't believe Diablo trounced me. He's beyond anything I've faced before."

Footsteps. The sound of heavy hiking boots stomp toward me, until their wearer comes to a stop a few feet to my left. I turn my head to look up at him, but the sun beams down into my eyes, making his face hard to see.

"Ah, so you're the one causing all the ruckus." I can barely make out a toothy smile on the man's face as he stares down at me. Turning away, he reaches toward a low-hanging branch on the tree and plucks a fruit from it. Slowly, the man bites into it, and the juices roll down his chin. "Mmm. I could eat a peach for hours."

"Who are you?" I ask the question, not out of curiosity, but fascination. "I've never seen you before."

The man shrugs. "Oh, you've seen me before, I assure you of that. I'm many people. Father, son, guard, prisoner. I fly, and I swim, and I do anything else that meets my fancy. A free spirit, if you will."

"Are you... the Creator?" I almost feel embarrassed to ask the question, but the man laughs.

"Hah, perhaps. Some have worshiped me, it's true. Some things are true whether you believe in them or not." He kneels down and sits beside me, but no matter how I squint, I can't make out his face. "What's on your mind, Jason?"

He knows my name. That thought, for some reason, warms my heart. "A lot of things. I have to make peace between a bunch of jackasses who won't look past their differences. There's so much riding on my shoulders, and the one thing I have going for me, which is that I'm good at fighting, isn't enough to let me beat the *third* most powerful of the demons. I can't do anything right."

Slowly, the man scratches his chin. "Ah, so there's a lot of pressure on you to perform well. I love pressure, personally. I eat it for breakfast." He stops scratching, and leans his back against the tree, gazing up into the sky. "You're stepping into a battlefield, not of fists, but of ideas. Both

sides have hurt each other deeply, for a very long time. A few pretty words won't solve anything. What's wrong can never be made right."

I close my eyes. "So it's pointless to try, after all?"

"No." The man looks at me seriously. "If there's something wrong, those who have the *ability* to take action have the *responsibility* to take action. Only a few people can solve the crisis in the Labyrinth, but just one person has the will and desire to do so."

"Me?"

"Mhm." He rumbles the response in his throat, rather than vocalizing. "It won't be easy. I've been faced with enemies myself, ones that seemed insurmountable at the time, but that I eventually overcame. Every muscle in my body didn't want to fight, but I did anyway. You just have to soldier forward, and power on."

"You're so wise..." The words slip out of my mouth, and I blush a little bit.

"Not particularly. I'm just giving you words, platitudes, general guidance. For all you know, I picked them out of a self-help book." He reaches into his pocket and pulls out a cigarette. After lighting it, he takes a long, slow drag. "I came here to drink myself to death. Instead, I ended up talking to you. Life is funny like that."

"Don't do that. You have to take care of yourself, uh, sir." I pull myself into a sitting position and squint even harder at the man. "I don't want to be rude, but I can't place your face. Have I seen you before?"

"Probably," The man says, as he turns his back to me. "For a while, I was all the people could talk about. My time is over, but my memory lives on. After you die, you will stay in the hearts of those who were with you."

The soft grass crumbles under his boots as he slowly walks away, leaving me behind.

I yell at him as he walks away, "See you later, Mister! Thanks for the advice! I'll work harder from now on."

"Rockin' good news."

Soon, the man is out of sight, and the world around me melts away...

* * *

"He's awake." A breathless voice speaks, just to my right side. It takes a moment for me to place it, but I realize it's Samantha's. "Remember what we said."

"Huh? Remember what?" I slur my words a little bit, but slowly open my eyes to see Samantha and Cassiel above me. Both look nervous, but they're trying so valiantly to hide it

from me.

"Nothing!" Cassiel exclaims, as her nervous smile widens more. "Are you doing okay? It took a lot of energy to heal you!"

"I'm fine, I guess." I pull myself into a sitting position, as memories flood back to me. "Ah! Diablo! I fought him. I lost. What happened to him?"

Samantha bites her lip. "He- um, came here..."

"And he was carrying you!" Cassiel chimes in quickly. "He was going to kill you, but-"

"-but the brave soldiers here blasted him with everything they had!" Samantha finishes Cassiel's sentence. Both of them almost seem to be making up a story as they go along. Samantha quickly turns her head to look at a nearby man in uniform. "Isn't that right?"

The man's face turns white. "Uh- err, yes! We, err, that is to say, shot him. Many times!"

"Uh huh..." I try to sound like I'm buying it, but something doesn't quite make sense. Before I can comment on the weird way everyone is acting, Samantha rests her hand on mine.

"These brave humans fought with all their might to save you. You should be thanking them!"

I feel a little awkward questioning her at a time like this, so I just nod dumbly and try my hardest to flash a genuine smile at the humans milling around. "Um, thanks for the save, guys!"

Everyone nearby averts their gaze, and they shuffle away nervously, leaving me to wonder what the hell happened while I was out. I glance down at Samantha's hand, still resting on mine. "Oh, Samantha. There's something stuck on your knuckle."

"HUH?!" She quickly pulls her hand away to glance at it. Just before she plucks the thing out, I get a slightly better look at it.

"Is that a *tooth*?"

"No!" She plucks the enameled object out of her knuckle, and pinches it together, crushing it into dust. "M-must have been a bone that grew out wrong. I didn't notice it until now!"

That was totally a tooth. She's hiding something. Still, it wouldn't be polite to question my girlfriends.

"Eh, whatever. Where did Diablo go, anyway? Did the humans kill him?"

A creepy look appears in Samantha's eyes. "Nope. That would be too easy."

"What?"

"Nothing!" She quickly jumps to her feet and adjusts her long-sleeved shirt. "Um, now that you're awake, and everyone knows I'm a demon... can you change my clothes back? These rags are really uncomfortable!"

Changing the topic, huh? "Yeah. **Reform.** " The clothes on her body shift and change. After the clothes revert to their original form, I glance from Sam's exposed chest over to Cassiel, to be a gentleman. "Did the humans win the battle?"

"Something like that," Cass replies. "Around twenty thousand men and women perished, and twice as many demons by a rough estimate. Samantha and I were pulling out all the stops to heal everyone, but our efforts still weren't nearly enough."

Samantha glances from Cass to me. "The king was nearly assassinated mid-battle. Two shadow-walkers tried to kill him while he was separated from his men for a split-second, but Cass saved him just in the nick of time."

"I'm glad to hear that," I say, pausing and realizing what I said. "The saving-the-king part, not the him-getting-stabbed part. Good job on that. Where is Cody now?"

Cassiel clears her throat. "Ahem, *King Elshard*, as is his proper title, is back in Hero City. You were out for over an hour. All the tunnels leading from this forward portal and into the Labyrinth have been sealed off. Everyone is pulling back and sealing the portal. The only way from Hero City to the Labyrinth will eventually be the great doors we entered from."

"That's a good move. After facing Diablo myself, I don't think humanity should aggravate the situation any further. If we can barely beat Diablo, we certainly can't overcome billions, if not trillions of lower level demons."

Samantha fidgets as I stand up. "Yeah, beating Diablo would be, ah, pretty hard. Haha." Her nervous laugh makes me raise an eyebrow, but she quickly changes the topic. "Um, before you do anything else, I should tell you, love... I need to go for a while."

"Huh? Yeah, I mean, go ahead, Sam. You don't need my permission." I try not to look too concerned, but she shifts her shoulders around and fidgets uncomfortably, averting her eyes from mine.

"Well, it won't be for a few hours, or a day. I need to go and speak with the Demon High Council. I'll probably be back in, say, a week or two."

"Uh huh. Okay. Mind if I ask why?"

Samantha freezes up. "Well, ah, that is, it's just- you see, things happened, and I have to go chat with the other demons about this and that..."

She trails off, and Cassiel finishes for her. "It's private, Hero. Can't you let a woman have a few secrets?"

"You know what this is about, Cass?" I direct a pointed question at her, but Cassiel just tilts her head away.

"Maybe! It's nothing malicious, anyway. Just let Sammy go and take care of some business. It's not like the bed will be cold or anything."

"That's... not why I was asking..." Sighing, I rub my forehead. "Never mind. Samantha, if you have something to take care of, go for it. Just be careful. I don't know how the other demons are going to feel about you, since you've been hanging out with humans, but if you need help, don't hesitate to ask, okay?"

Cassiel scoffs. "Pfft. Like a horde of demons could ever lay a hand on-"

"Cass!" Samantha squeaks and swats the angel on the shoulder. "It's embarrassing!"

I'm *really* interested in what went down while I was out, but it's apparent these two aren't going to give me so much as a hint. "I know you're plenty strong, Samantha. It's nothing to get all bashful over. I'm glad you're my girl, and that's all there is to it."

She blushes and crosses her arms. "Aww, you can be such a sweetie. I'm gonna be lonely while I'm gone."

I pull her and Cassiel in close while staring at the people milling about. "Then let's have a good time tonight."

"Yeah!" Cassiel chimes in excitedly, and as we turn away, something catches my eye.

"Hey, what's that giant blood splatter near that tunnel? Isn't that the direction I went to fight Diablo? There's a bunch of red flesh chunks all over the ground as well and-"

"It's nothing! Seven Devils, let's just go!" Samantha shoves me along, and I snicker to myself as we head to the portal leading back to Hero City. *I think I know what went down.*

* * *

"Rats." Tvoorik kicks his foot out from under his bench and sends some orc bones scattering against the wall. "What the heaven are humans made of? I must've stabbed that king fifty times!"

"Four times," I say, correcting him. I swirl the Blood Soup around my bowl aimlessly. "The last one was sloppy, too. You barely even scratched his arm."

"Sh-shut yer trap, Ylvusk! I didn't see you doing any stabbing!"

"I was holding him down and using my shadow-phasing to distract his guards. I thought you could handle stabbing one fleshbag to death. Why didn't you stab him in the heart, or slit his throat?"

Tvoorik glares at me before spinning in his seat and kicking the wall again. "I thought I did stab his heart."

"It's the other side of the chest, dumbass. I guess you nicked a lung maybe. Did you even plunge the knife in deep?"

He can't even make eye contact with me. "I don't remember..."

"You're hopeless." I take a quick spoonful of the delicious, iron-rich blood, and feel the dead cells roll past my tongue and down my throat. Smacking my lips, I remark, "At least we didn't die, and we ended up better off than Diablo. Poor bastard."

Tvoorik's sullen expression vanishes as his sadism takes over. "And Bael! Both of them got the beatdown of a lifetime! But you know, this just proves my theories right!"

"Satan the Devil, not this nonsense again." I curse under my breath, then glance around at the few scattered demons in the 71st dining area. All of them are pretty far away, but if they happen to hear his stupid theories, they might think less of me, too.

Tvoorik nods eagerly. "Think about it! We saw that human, the one named Hero, and the Second Emperor and an Angel was with him! All the pieces finally fit together!"

"What... pieces...?" I can barely even bring myself to ask the question.

"The entire battle was a sham. Diablo sent the weaker demons as the vanguard, and thousands of them died. The humans we killed were sent to the River, and those souls flowed up to him! He eliminated a bunch of competition for souls, and drained plenty of soul energy for himself too! And don't forget, Belial was there just in case we killed too many of the humans! She's getting soul energy as well!"

"If you say so."

He continues, ignoring my disinterest in the conversation. "And the appearance of that angel can mean only one thing! The angels are in league with the demons! The First Emperor is using his two strongest fellow emperors to play both sides against each other, and he's keeping the demons in reserve in case the humans get too antsy."

I stare at Tvoorik's dumb, excited face for a few moments. "That angel is the last one alive. All the rest are dead. Gressil said so himself."

"No way! Only a dummy would believe that orc-crap! Other angels are still alive, and they work for the demons! It's the only thing that makes sense! We know humans can't use magic, so it must have been the angel that destroyed one of our planets with a meteor and blew up another one's star. That angel is the key; I bet she's coming up with any manner of devious plots. She might be pulling the strings behind the scenes, for all we know!"

My soup is getting cold. I barely even want to eat any more of it. "Anything's possible." *If you're a moron*, I think to myself.

From across the room, Smealum enters. Sighing heavily, he rubs his head, where a big, ugly bruise is swelling up. He spots us and immediately trudges over, shoving Tvoorik aside on the bench to make room for himself.

"I see you guys made it out alive. Failed your mission, though."

Tvoorik snuffles and turns his head away from the Eldest Animus. "I couldn't help it! That human was a master of hand-to-hand combat. He deflected my blows and parried my attacks, plus his guardsmen outnumbered Ylvusk and me a hundred to one! And they had those anti-energy guns, AND the king had like, TWO big robots that started attacking us. We barely made it out alive!"

Smealum shoots me a somber look. "He loves his tall-tales, doesn't he?"

"To say the least." Despite my earlier annoyance, now that Smealum is here, an idea comes to me. I quickly reach under my side of the table, into a pouch beside me, and pull out a few ebony chits. "Hey, Smealum. It's been a long day. Whaddya say the three of us play a few friendly games of Stones and Bones, eh? Rental fee is on me."

The animus smirks. "I'm not betting anything on these games. I used my luck on that Hydra toss. The Devils won't favor me again for a long time." He pauses to scratch his chin. "But hey, if you're payin', I'm playin'."

"That's the spirit." I wink at him and jump up from my seat to chat with the dining manager.

It's time I actually did something enjoyable with my day.

Part 450c: I, Demon

My eyes blink open to the odd feeling of my ears both being nibbled on. I almost leap out of bed, thinking the sensation is due to earwigs, but as soon as I start to move, I realize my arms are pinned. The sensation stops, and I turn my head in both directions to see Cassiel and Samantha winking at me.

"Sammy was right! The look on your face was perfect." Cass snickers to herself before leaning forward and pecking me on the cheek. "After all the hard work you put in last night, I'm surprised we managed to wake you up."

Samantha drags her hair across my chest. "You were *snoring*. I don't think I've ever heard that before, at least not from you."

"I don't even remember falling asleep, or what I dreamed about. My dreams have been fairly good lately, too."

The succubus's smirk falters. "I didn't sleep at all. Too much to think about." Immediately after the words leave her mouth, she blushes and turns away. "Err, it's no big deal though."

Cass and I share a quick glance before I turn back to Sam. "Want to talk about it? I'm not sure exactly why you have to leave anyway."

Rolling onto her back, Samantha pulls the covers up to her chin. "Um. Well, you see, it's about my- my ah, the actions I've taken of late... and my ranking in demon society."

"Uh huh..." I mutter a soft response, and after a few moments, she continues.

"I killed Gressil. I've been traveling around with the last angel, and a human who, erm, killed a bunch of demons. My actions haven't been befitting of the Second Emperor... so..." Her voice trails off.

Gently, I pull myself into a sitting position. "So, what, are you going to be punished? Stripped of rank? Or... worse?!" A tinge of alarm enters my voice before I can catch myself, but Samantha just shrugs under the covers.

"Dunno. It's never happened before. Demons at the top standing against other demons, that is. The one trait we always shared with angels was our loyalty to those at the top of the pecking order."

Cassiel spins around and flops on top of me to look at Samantha. Her wings, despite her best effort, end up shoving feathers in my face. "Wait, when did you turn against your fellow demons? You never did that! Tell those stuffy bureaucrats they're full of squat!"

With a shifty glance, Samantha squints at Cass. "Um. Those 'stuffy bureaucrats' are friends and acquaintances of mine. The only people who could put me on trial are member of the demon council, which is comprised of the eight highest ranking demons, though the First Emperor never attends. Usually, I wouldn't either, but..."

Cass finishes her sentence for her. "...But you're the one under trial. Are you sure you don't want us to go with you?"

"This is my ordeal," Samantha replies, before her usual playful smile comes back. "Besides, even if the entire council decided to attack me, it wouldn't go well unless the First Emperor was there." Her eyes suddenly look at me and that odd bashfulness returns. "I- I mean, it's not that they're all afraid of me or something! Don't look at me like that!"

"Sam, seriously, it's okay. I know you're physically strong. It's kinda sexy, in a way." I slip my hand under the covers and clasp her hand in mine. "Heck, knowing you're going into a hostile environment, the only reason I'm not super worried is that I know you're a big girl and you can protect yourself. I- puah!" Cassiel's wing shifts a little bit and shoves into my mouth, so I gag on her feathers for a second before reaching up and tugging the damn thing off. "These wings of yours are so unwieldy sometimes!"

Cass glares at me, her face just inches from mine. "Hey! I didn't ask for these wings, you know. Anyway, they're soft and fluffy and sleeping on them always feels like having a mattress made of down, so I bet you're just jealous. Nyeh!" She sticks her tongue out at me, as Samantha giggles in response.

"Oh, geez! You two! I'm going to be so *bored* for the next two weeks. I don't even know how I'll pass the time! Half of the reason it's going to take so long is that I have to travel all the way to the Council, and that's a multiple-day trip even teleporting around at high speeds."

Samantha reaches up through the covers to tap her lips thoughtfully, and Cassiel climbs off me and crawls out of bed. "Hero could teleport you directly there, Sam. Why not do that?"

"Mmm, thanks, but no thanks. I'm in enough trouble without telling the number one enemy of demonkind where their leaders are located." Sam quickly turns to look at me. "And that means no using 'locate' to follow me around!"

"Gosh, Samantha. I'm not a stalker." I roll away from her and crawl out of bed, sighing at the sweaty mess we've left behind. "Though if you're not back in two weeks, is it at least okay if I check on you somehow?"

"I wouldn't have it any other way." She smiles at me and pulls the covers away to reveal her voluptuous body. "You know, before I leave, I should clean myself up and look presentable. All three of us look pretty gross right now, so..."

Silently, I stare at her for a few moments, pretending I'm a dummy. "I don't understand. What are you hinting at?"

Cass pokes me in the rib, making me jump in surprise. "Omygosh, don't be a butt! Let's all jump in the shower before she leaves. I feel embarrassed even saying it!"

"You two are so antsy about the silliest stuff," I say, smiling as I head into the bathroom. "I'll warm the water up."

It takes a minute, but once the water is heated, I stick my head out the door. "Come on in, it's the perfect temp-" I pause, noticing that Howard has woken up and is waddling around the room, chasing after the nude figures of both girls.

"Wark. Wark." He quacks at them and scurries around as they both giggle and laugh, and both of them quickly run past me and climb in the shower, while the duck stops just outside the door and stares up at me.

"Wark." His eyes narrow as he stares at my manhood hanging out in full view.

I lean down and stare him right in the eye. Keeping my voice down so the girls can't hear me over their splashing, I whisper to him. *"You think I don't see what's going on? You think I don't see your sick game? They're mine, you little bastard. No matter how cute you think you are, their hearts belong to me. You mean nothing to them other than being a quick distraction, a motorcycle breezing past doing 180 on the interstate. You're just a leaf caught in the wind, but I am a rock in the ocean, bearing all their weight. You will never be as close to them as I am now, do you hear me, you little punk?"*

Howard continues to stare at me. "Wark."

"Hah, just kidding. You're a cute ducky." Saying this, I quickly pat the little guy on the head, then close the door immediately and climb into the shower with the girls.

* * *

An hour or two later, Samantha inhales deeply as the three of us walk down the steps toward the Palace's entrance. She tosses her thick, black hair around, letting it splay all over her shoulders. "What a bother. If demons weren't so obstinate, I swear, there are times when I'd just like to-" She finishes her sentence with some guttural grumbles that don't translate to real words.

Cassiel trots along on my right, glancing past me at Samantha now and then. She casually stretches, before saying, "Oh, I don't know. At least demons know what they want. They always fight toward achieving their goals, and I think that's praiseworthy." A pause, as she considers her words. "Well, aside from the fact the goals of the demons are somewhat genocidal."

"Yeah..." Samantha trails off before looking up into the cloudy blue sky. "Though, based on what happened during the Energy Wars, I can safely say all the sentients are awful in their own ways. At least humans and angels don't make light of devouring the flesh of their enemies."

I curl up my lips in disgust at the same time as Cass does. "I was going to eat later. Maybe I'll pass. Why do demons do that anyway?" Another thought occurs to me. "Not to be rude, but have you ever-"

"No! Gross!" Samantha instantly scowls at me as we arrive at the palace gates. "Not all demons eat humans, Jason."

Despite the solemn look on Samantha's face, Cassiel giggles. "Well, you DO eat the essence of humans, in a way."

"D-different. That's very different." Samantha stops just before we leave the palace, and taps her foot. "Demons take soul energy from humans and add it to their own to increase their power. This can happen in a variety of ways, and all of them result in the deaths of the victim. I've heard demons can take the energy of other demons similarly, but that would be a matter involving punishment by the council."

Her words make me feel ill at the possibilities. "Do demons *have* to consume human flesh, then? Does that mean that we can never have peace without offering up virgin women to your people?"

Surprisingly, Samantha smiles. "No. It's a matter of greed. Demons can easily subsist on a diet, not unlike humans. As a succubus, my immortality is dependent on, erm, male essence, but many have survived, and even thrived, by limiting their 'portions'. Most other demons don't have a similar handicap though and will live on forever eating food that humans would consider ordinary. It has to do with pride though, Jason. Ninety-five percent of demons are the very lowest levels of mutations, but the five percent of matriarchs and patriarchs have unfathomable power because they've secured their footholds already."

She pauses and looks away from me to Cassiel. "The trouble is convincing them to accept their lot in life. As it is, the River Styx takes the souls of all humans who die and gives it to the Demon Emperors to distribute. This process will happen regardless of how the humans pass on, so it's just a matter of time before all humans eventually become food for demons." Spotting the looks of marvel and disgust on our faces, Samantha quickly continues, "You should know, this is very similar to what the angels used originally for their resurrection system. In any case, most demons love the taste of human flesh. It's a delicacy, you might say."

Cassiel smacks her lips dryly. "Yum."

"I know. It's gross." Samantha's foot tapping slows and stops as she turns away to look at the Great Doors in the distance. "Anyway, convincing demons to abandon the pursuit of human flesh would be the ultimate test of diplomacy. Demons are often greedy and selfish, and they would love nothing more than to kill all the humans as quickly as possible to reap their souls, not realizing that once all humans are dead, there won't be any souls left to absorb. It's a lose-lose situation for both sides."

At last, I spot what Sam's been driving toward. "You think there's a way to make peace a possibility, then?"

"Of course. Both sides are fighting due to past differences, which can be forgiven, but the overall goals are different. A bargain can be struck; I just don't see by whom."

Cassiel steps around me and wraps her arm around Samantha's. "Why not you? You're an influential lady. You rank high among demons, and you have lots of experience with humans. Why don't you?"

"I can't." Samantha cuts Cassiel off and pulls away from her grasp. "I've lost the respect of the demons. I was never present as a leader. I fought against them during this recent battle, and in their eyes, I've allied myself with their worst enemies. I have no political tongue anyway. I'm no good at giving speeches and dumb stuff like that." She crosses her arms and rubs her shoulders, sighing deeply. "I'd be useless."

Cassiel looks bummed that Sam would shut her down so quickly. "Oh. Okay."

After a few moments of awkwardness, Samantha lowers her arms to her sides again. "I'm going to head off. Like I said, I'll be back in a couple of weeks. Take care of yourselves."

"Wait. Hold on." I step in front of her to block her path before she can sullenly stomp off. "We're still going to walk you to the gate."

She gives me a half-hearted smile, before brushing past. "I'm not mad or anything, Jason. All this talk has simply reminded me of all my failures during my life. I'll walk myself, just this once, okay?"

I open my mouth to respond, but she presses her finger to my lips. "Shh. Love you." Leaning up she kisses me softly, and before I can reciprocate, she pulls away. "Take care of our Hero, Cass. I'll be back soon."

Saying this, she turns and walks away, her posture having a slump to it I haven't seen before. Cassiel stammers at her, "I l-love you too, Sammy! Take care of yourself!"

Seconds turn into a minute, and before long, Samantha rounds a building in the distance and walks out of sight.

"Mmm... I don't feel good about this." Cassiel rubs her sandals against the cobblestone and stamps her foot. "Why did she suddenly take off like that? Was it something I said?"

"I think we accidentally hit a nerve, Cass. It's like if someone was talking about being a prisoner of war and it bothered you, reminding you of your life. Some people have things they don't want to think about, even if it seems silly to us."

"It's not *silly*, per se... I just think Sammy's overthinking things because she's anxious." Cass rubs her hands together, looks at me, then back into the distance where Samantha left. "Ohhh it's all my fault! I said something that pissed her off! I'm such a jerk!"

"It isn't your fault. Relax." I reach over and rub her shoulders gently, but the tension doesn't fade. "If it makes you feel better, why not fly after her and talk with her before she leaves. I get the feeling she's concerned because talking about things in front of me is exposing a side of herself she usually doesn't show to the men in her life. You'll have a better chance alone than with me there."

"You think so?" Cassiel's lip quivers as she stares ahead. "I still see her spirit trail... okay! I-I'll go chase her down and catch her before she leaves. I won't be gone long!" She barely glances back at me before pulling away and jumping into the air, letting her wings carry her up into the sky, where she can easily see Samantha's 'spirit trail' amidst the winding network of buildings and houses.

"Have fun," I mutter at nobody in particular.

Despite looking like a falcon in the distance, Cassiel's flight speed is unthinkable faster than any bird I've ever seen. Within seconds she turns into a speck in the sky, before diving down into the mess of buildings.

Now what do I do?

I suddenly realize what Samantha meant when she said she'd be bored without Cassiel and I beside her. I've grown so used to having the girls nearby, that I feel a little depressed when they aren't. The three of us are practically inseparable at this point.

Turning around, I trudge joylessly back into the palace. *I suppose there's Ionis*, I think to myself. *I could chat him up. I'm sure he'll be suuuuch a joy to talk to. I wish I had someone to play Chess with. That's the one thing neither Samantha nor Cassiel is ever interested in doing. If only they liked Chess, they'd be the perfect girlfriends.*

The sound of feet walking up and stopping interrupt my thoughts. "Oh. It's you." A woman's voice from my right makes me turn to look in her direction. A blonde girl, maybe twenty-five or twenty-six years old, wearing an odd white armor with a golden eagle across the front of it,

stares me up and down. "Jason Hiro? The Wordsmith?" Her helmet is half open, so I can only somewhat make out her face.

I nod at her blankly. "Yeah. That's me. Most people call me 'Hero' around here, though, haha." I offer a smile to her along with my awkward laughter, but she doesn't smile back.

Her armor is unique. It looks different from anything I saw on the battlefield combatants. She has an aura about her, like that of a leader. Perhaps she's a commander in the military? I don't know many people in the chain of command very well. Then there's the matter of the long sword strapped to her side, wrapped in a beautiful golden scabbard. Flashy, but who uses a sword against demons? Isn't a gun more efficient?

She squints at me. "You look different than I remember. The glowing tattoos especially. How old are you?"

"Do I know you? I don't remember meeting you..." I trail off, but she doesn't answer my question. "I'm thirty-five. Why do you ask?"

The girl raises an eyebrow. "Years? Not hundreds of years, or millennia, but just years?"

"Uh. Yeah?" Now I'm perplexed. She's suspicious as hell. "Who are you?"

A look of irritation passes over the girl's face, as she looks to her right and left before turning back to me. "When was your arrival point? Do you know what the Sword of Damocles is?"

I continue to stare at her blankly, but an odd feeling, deep in the back of my lizard-brain, starts to buzz. "You're asking an awful lot of questions, and you haven't answered any of mine. Why don't you tell me who you are, and then we can continue with the pleasantries-"

She cuts me off and glances down at a display on her wrist. "Damn. I'm in the wrong stream. Forget you saw me. It was a false reading."

A moment later she surprises me by taking off into a dead run, moving much faster than an ordinary human could.

"Hey! Wait!" Before she can dash out the front door, I yell at her. " **Stop!** "

She continues running, as if my magic has no effect. *What the fuck?*

Using the agility the gods have given me, I leap after her, chasing her afterimage through the palace courtyard. The moment she glances back and sees me in pursuit, it's as if someone fires off a gun to signal a race. A blast of energy surges out of the armor from her back, and her helmet closes up. She races forward at a speed far exceeding anything a human can muster.

That's when the alarm bells coalesce. *She's a demon!* I've seen the type before. She might look like a human, but it's a disguise. How she got her hands on such an advanced piece of

technology is something I'll have to find out later.

" **Speed!** " I yell out the word and increase my agility even further, dashing out the palace gates after her. Men and women yell in surprise as we rush past, the wind following us in our wakes.

Still, this demoness keeps her speed up. Each time I reach forward to grab her, she ducks, dodges, or jumps to the side with an inhuman level of agility.

"Goddamnit! Stop, you crazy bitch! I just want to talk!" Throwing logic out the window, I curse at her with the hopes she'll slow down. She's a slippery fucker, that much is for sure.

Only once we arrive in the main city do my problems truly blow up. She leaps through the window of a house, smashing out the panes of glass and scaring the shit out of whoever lives in there. I jump after and dive past furniture and other crap, nearly kicking some poor little tyke right in the face, but dodging him at the last second, before diving out their other window.

Just when I thought she couldn't be any more of a ninja, the woman begins teleporting short distances, this way and that, and a strange magic field begins to form in front of her. *Almost as if she's building up energy for something!*

As we race down the street, past this vendor and that, she deliberately reaches out and slaps a stall of apples out, hurling them behind herself to slow me down. It barely works, but it distracts me just enough that I almost don't notice the bright flash of light where she once was.

I come to a screeching halt, still breathing evenly, and gaze around.

The woman is gone.

"Who the- no, *what* the fuck was that?" I say, to nobody at all.

"Hero! Hero?" Cassiel's voice, in the sky above. She flies down and lands beside me. "What happened? I heard a sound like a sonic boom, and saw you run past. Are you okay?"

Silently, I grind my teeth together. It takes me a few moments to respond. "Someone just tried to pull a joke on me, and it wasn't funny. Not in the slightest."

The wind from my wake catches up and gently blows past us, as I stare at the spot the woman vanished. " **Locate.** "

Whoever that was, I lost my chance to find out her identity.

Part 451c: Bloody Good Times

The third most powerful demon in existence, Diablo, limps down the hallway. His small entourage of a half-dozen guards, ordinarily unnecessary for one of such power as he, have been summoned due to the grievous wounds he suffered at the hands of the Second Emperor, Belial.

He almost trips over a small rock, but before one of the guards can reach forward to steady him, Diablo snarls at the scyther, "No! I don't need help walking."

The lesser demon pulls away and smirks behind his leader's back. "Belial hurt you pretty good. You shouldn't have pissed her off, boss."

"Obviously." Diablo glances at his shoulder, where a giant chunk of flesh is missing. Already the wound is turning a dull brown. "Seven Devils. This festering flesh burns like the fires of Tartarus. I'd kill for some ice."

Two of his guards glance at each other before looking at their emperor. "We could summon an Ice Gypsy, my liege. I believe there might be one in the 425th District."

"Let us see what Hellga has to say first." Diablo rounds the final corner, breathing heavily as he finally enters the Recuperation Quarters in his district. It's a place where demons injured in battle, and of sufficient value that they're worth healing, would typically retreat. He wrinkles his nose as the smell of many ointments and bubbling, oozing wounds greet him. The demons behind him are even more uncomfortable.

"Hellga. Hellga!" He coughs the words out, choking as another chunk of phlegm catches in his throat. "Where are you, woman?"

An imp scurries up to Diablo's feet, looks him up and down, then bows several times quickly. "The mistress is attending to the sick, master Diablo sir! Nyeh heh! Take a seat, and she'll be with you in a few minutes!"

"She'll be with me *now*. I'm the Third Emperor of our people. My life is more valuable than the lower classes."

The imp squirms uncomfortably. "Mmm, y-yes, of course! As you wish, oh great one! Nyeh heh heh!" Cackling like a hyena, the imp scurries away, and Diablo limps over to a nearby bench and carefully sits down on it, wincing as his shattered hip-bone rests on the cold demonstone.

"Gah! That Belial, she knows where to punch to maximize damage."

"How'd she beat you anyway, Emperor Diablo?" One of his guards leans against a wall and pulls a bloodied sausage out from his cloak, and starts munching on it.

"I'm never sure. I've fought Belial just twice in my life before and lost both times. This last fight was the third. I believe she uses her bewitching aura in combat to put me at a disadvantage. My blows were sluggish and weak compared to when I've fought other demons, such as Bael. Then again, it may just be that she's so adept at combat, despite loathing violence, that I simply can't lay a hand on her."

His guardsman smacks his lips as he takes another bite of the sausage. "Is it true you didn't land a single hit on her?"

"Sadly."

Diablo's shallow breaths turn to slightly stinging pain as the minutes tick past. His battered ribs rise and fall in time with his chest, each movement a painful reminder of the savage defeat he was handed at the fists of one of the two demons who could easily kill him in the Labyrinth.

"Seven Devils. I thought I told that demoness to hurry up." Diablo grumbles to himself, but at that moment, the sound of footsteps rounds the corner.

An ugly old hag with bags under her eyes and droopy skin skulks forward, and rasps at him, "Oh look. It's the other one. Got your ass beat, didja?"

"Yes." Diablo's reply is curt. "I need healing."

"What a shocker. I'd never have guessed, since you showed up injured at the healing headquarters. What's next, are you gonna pop over to the mess hall and tell them you're hungry?"

Diablo gnashes his teeth. "For devil's sake! Can you cut the chatter and heal me already?! I need to be back on the frontlines as soon as possible."

Hellga blinks slowly at the Third Emperor, deliberately keeping her eyes closed for a split-second before opening them again, as if to non-verbally ask, *are you stupid?* "I hope you aren't in a rush, great leader. You're in worse condition than Bael. With wounds like those, it'll be a few months at best."

"What do you mean? Just use magic, heal me up, and I can leave this place." With an effort not unlike trying to shove a boulder by sneezing on it, Diablo pulls himself to his feet and staggers toward the old bat.

"Healing magic? If you wanted that, you should have asked Belial. She's the best healer among us. Nobody else comes close."

Diablo stares at the hag, dumbfounded. "Belial is the one who did this to me. Do you mean you have no healing magic? I thought you were the second greatest healer among demons!"

A shrug. "If Emperor Satan were alive, I'd be third. As it stands, I do possess some restorative spells, but at best they will remove some toxins and patch up the skin. The internal damage will need to be healed in the Blood Vats."

The third emperor stares at the old woman for a few long moments. "Blood Vats?"

"When was the last time you were injured, tubby?" She pauses and thinks the question over. "Correction: When was the last time you were injured and afterward healed by someone other than Belial?"

Diablo glances back at his guards before turning back to Hellga. "It's been... a few eons or so."

"Mmm. We lost a few healers during the human invasion. Our healing quarters are nearer to the lairs of humanity, just in case invasions turn south and demons require medical attention, as I'm sure you know. It's a double-edged fang, as this puts our most proficient in harm's way." She tosses her hands up in the air. "Oh well! Unless you wish to apologize to Belial, there's no getting past it. You and Bael both will be out of the fight for a while."

Curses. Diablo's mind rages with thoughts. *If only I could ask the First Emperor for help. He might be able to heal me, but it would be so humiliating to ask. I'll have to appoint a proxy while I recuperate. Belial has been summoned before the Council, so after they determine her punishment... perhaps Mephisto? Agares? Barbatos? Someone must lead the war effort.*

As the thoughts roil through his mind, Hellga grows impatient and taps her foot. "Are you done wasting my time? I have many injured males and females to attend to after you. You've certainly given me plenty of injured to care for, *some* more grateful than *others*."

The Third Emperor grimaces. "Fine. Let us begin. The sooner I heal, the sooner I can be back on my feet."

Hellga rolls her eyes. "And the quicker I have one less whiner to attend to. Come along." She starts to turn away, but pauses. "Those guards of yours are going to take up a lot of room. They'd better get their grub from elsewhere. The food here is for patients only."

The guard from before holds up his nearly finished sausage. "I'm good."

Another shoves him rudely. "No need to rub it in our faces! Some of us haven't eaten since the battle, you fat oaf!"

Diablo's stomach growls. "You with the sausage. Go and grab food for the rest of them."

"Aw, rats." The guard scarfs the rest of his sausage down and sighs. "Fine! I'll be back."

As he stomps off, Hellga beckons, and Diablo follows after her, along with his five remaining guards. They round several corners, passing demons who are violently ill, some missing limbs,

and others moaning in delirium before she stops in front of a small hut.

"This houses the blood vats. Only Dukes and Emperors may use these, unless we're stuffed to capacity. Luckily, you won't have to wallow in misery all by yourself. You have a friend." She rolls her eyes again. "And based on how he won't stop complaining about you, I'm sure your conversations will be *delightful*."

She pulls the cover back from the hut's doorway and Diablo's already pained body creaks miserably as he spots Bael staring at him, laying up to his neck in a bloody concoction from a hole in the ground.

"Oh, great. Here to beat me to a pulp again?"

Diablo sighs. "Bael."

"Diablo."

Bael watches as Hellga guides the third over to a pit directly across from his fellow duke. "You two are the only ones here, so I assume you'll be good company for each other."

"Sure." Diablo keeps his voice neutral as he stares at the pit filled with blood. "What is this? Just blood? From what?"

"Humans, of course." Hellga leans forward and dips her finger in the liquid, pulls it to her mouth, and licks heartily. "Not as good as the soup or other concoctions, but adequate for healing purposes."

Diablo grimaces slightly. "I do love a good Blood Soup, but how will bathing in human blood make me heal faster?"

"Human blood is toxic for themselves, but it has many beneficial properties for a demon. Just get in already!" Hellga's polite tone turns sour as her patience wears thin once more. "Don't be a baby!"

The Third Emperor nods, strips his ragged pants off, then carefully lowers himself inside the pit. "Ahh... this does feel quite relaxing."

Hellga, finally satisfied that he's ready, turns toward the door, shoos his guards outside. "These two need plenty of rest. You wait outside and guard the doorway. Just don't block my path! If one of you worthless simpletons dozes off in front of the door, I'll have your heads!"

Diablo chuckles slightly, despite the pain, as the nasty old bitch shoves his guards outside the door. After they've left, he tilts his head slightly to stare at Bael, who is gazing back.

"Well then."

"Yup." Bael scrunches up his face. "I'm guessing the Second tore you that new asshole?"

"Who else could it be? The human?"

Both demons share a good chuckle, and Bael reaches up from the blood to wipe away a tear of laughter. "That whelp couldn't even beat me! Not a chance he could lay a hand on you." A pause. "The Second is really somethin'."

The smile vanishes from Diablo's expression, as his aura turns grave. "Aye. With her flipping sides, and me out of the fight, plus the fact I can't rely on you for the immediate future, I don't know who could lead our people in battle against the humans. Perhaps Barbatos... he is ancient and has fought many battles, but his prowess on the battlefield is nowhere near the level needed to command the Demonic Legions."

With a smirk, Bael flicks some blood across the room at Diablo, but it falls short and splatters on the floor. "I s'pose the First will have to come out of hiding and lead the army himself. It's about time the bastard did some work."

The Third Emperor shakes his head as his eyes lower to the blood surrounding him. "He hides his identity for reasons unknown. If he hasn't shown himself yet, it will take something big to change that fact."

The two grow quiet as Diablo retreats to his thoughts.

After a few minutes, Bael chortles under his breath. "Hey, Diablo."

"What?"

"The blood's pretty tasty, but don't drink it. It gives you gas." Saying this, he squirms a little bit, and a giant bubble floats up from under the blood, popping on the surface.

Diablo scrunches his face up. "You're disgusting; you know that?"

"Mhm."

* * *

The walls race past in a blur as Samantha uses the agility granted to her by an all-powerful dragon from ages past, tearing down this corridor and that at half the speed of sound. Sometimes she leaps against a wall, pausing for a split second before jumping off it with a short burst of even faster acceleration.

Skeletons, demons, goblins, every manner of monster breezes past her as she deftly leaps, dodges, and runs against the walls here and there to avoid them.

From out of nowhere, a huge orc appears, blocking a cramped hallway. *No time to stop*, her mind screams! It's too late. Digging her heels in, she only manages to slow herself down before

slamming into the massive brute with tremendous force, smashing him against a wall at the end of the hallway.

Wincing, she pulls herself to her feet. "Oh gosh, are you okay there, big guy?" She quickly hops over to the orc, who is laying dazed against a wall. "I am soooo sorry! I'll heal you right up!"

After weaving some magic, she helps the orc to his feet, and he smiles politely at her, his two thick lower teeth sticking out and above his lips. "Ah, thank you, my lady. I thought I was at death's door, for certain."

Samantha frowns. "Err, you're welcome. How hard did you hit your head? I don't think I've ever heard an orc as well spoken as you."

The big green monster blushes. "Ah, I am... a clan elder! Yes, an aged one among my people. I am much more intelligent than the average brute you might associate with those called 'orcs.' My name is Grok."

Samantha scratches her chin. "Wow, I don't know much about orcs, but that's really something. Uh, my name is-"

"Belial, yes. The Second Emperor of the demons. You seem to be in quite a rush."

She smiles sweetly. "Ah, my face is very recognizable." The smile dissolves as she suddenly feels embarrassed. "Err, well, I'm heading to a council meeting right now. See, I kinda... well, I've done some stuff lately that tarnished my reputation a bit..."

"Collaborating with the humans, as I've heard." Grok picks up his staff from the ground and leans on it lightly. "I suppose you must feel some affinity toward them."

She averts her eyes, but he shakes his hand at her. "No no, it's nothing to be ashamed of, my dear. Humans do, after all, have some admirable qualities. All creatures hold a moral system, and none are truly superior to that of the others. Even my people, ignorant though they be in the ways of speech, care more for their brood spawn than do many of the other monster races. I consider it our finest feature."

Samantha looks back up at the huge, lumbering creature. "You are an odd one, after all. To hear a monster, and an orc at that, praising humans... it's a little abnormal."

"Oh, most certainly, my dear. But, to be fair, I have known some humans, an angel or two, and even a few of the Volgrim. I've been alive quite a long time, you see."

The succubus blinks in surprise. "Even a few Volgrim? Shouldn't I have heard of you, in that case? You must hold quite the influence to know someone from every race."

Grok wipes a small tuft of hair back with his hand. "I've been alive since before the Energy Wars. Due to unique circumstances, I've learned a bit of this and a bit of that. As I said, not all members of any given species fit perfectly into boxes with designated features. Why, from what I hear, some succubi and incubi despise sexual relations. Isn't that right?"

Sam sighs. "You got me there. You're the real deal." She cracks her neck and glances at the rest of the Labyrinth in the direction she was heading. "Well, um, in any case... I do need to be going, Elder Grok. It was nice talking with you."

"Mmm. And you as well." Before she can turn away, Grok reaches out and puts his hand on her shoulder. "Tell me, before you go... do you regret allying yourself with the humans?"

"Huh? No, not particularly..." Uneasiness sprouts in Samantha's mind, and she fidgets with her feet. "I mean, I just wish we could all get along, you know?"

"So you would change things if you knew how?"

"Well, maybe..."

"I see." Grok pulls his hand away. "You possess everything you need, but you lack just one thing on your journey. Sadly, it is not something even I can help you with. You must find it on your own."

Samantha stares at him, her mouth slightly open. "W-what's that?"

"Courage. You must learn to stand up proudly, and be more than what your species limits you. You must stop thinking of yourself as a succubus, and start picturing yourself as a leader. Your biology is not the barrier you think it is."

A warm feeling appears in Samantha's chest. "I... see. I hadn't thought of it like that before."

Grok gestures down the hallway from where she came. "Do you hear them? The voices?"

"Huh? What voices?" She leans forward to strain and listen, but Grok pulls her back.

"No no, I do not mean the words you can hear, I mean the words you *cannot* hear. You know they are spoken, but never in your presence. They hold you back. The other demons think of you not as a leader, but as a sex-fiend. You know this, but choose to pretend the words don't hurt, when they do. To move on, you must accept who you are, and only then will the courage come when the time is right." Grok smiles. "Trust me; I've read books."

Samantha nods, gazing at the lovable orc in awe. "Th-thank you. Nobody has ever spoken so frankly to me."

"The ones who care about you don't wish to hurt your feelings, and the ones who don't care, fear your power. However, words have a power of their own. Sometimes a single word can win a

war, where even the deadliest weapon could not."

In Samantha's mind, images of Jason appear. "Yeah. You're right about that."

"I certainly hope so. In any case, I'm sure you have places to be."

She blinks quickly, shaking the feeling of awe from her mind. "O-oh, right! Well, in any case, thank you, Elder Grok! You've helped more than you know."

"Oh, please, just call me Grok. Formalities are so stuffy and constricting." Grok winks at her before pulling away. "Tell you what; I'm going to create a portal to send you right to the council. I think you're more ready to face them now than you were before."

The girl blinks in surprise once more. "You're full of surprises. Eloquent, charming, knowledgeable, and you even have magic." Samantha steps away as Grok moves his hands to form magical signs. "If I weren't already taken, I could fall for you."

For once, the big orc blushes. "I am already with mate, myself. I do thank you for the offer though." Stretching out his hand, he closes his eyes as...

...nothing happens.

Samantha stares for a few moments. "Um."

"Just a moment."

Another few seconds pass "Err... maybe you messed up the sign? Those hand movements *were* a little clunky."

"No, no. It just takes a moment to- ah, there we go." A huge orb of blue expands in the hallway, as a portal just big enough for Samantha to step through opens up.

"That took longer than I expected. Do spells usually have a delay for you?"

Grok shrugs. "Sometimes."

"Cryptic. Well, I won't look a gift Hydra in the mouth. Thank you, Grok, for everything. You're a real devil." Samantha steps through the portal and waves, as it closes up behind her.

Moments pass, as Grok stares at the spot where she vanished. "That was a little awkward at the end, Daisy."

The girl appears at the end of the hallway and jogs up to her orc friend, squirming the whole way. "Sorry! I had to read your mind to figure out where to open it! You should have warned me first! That was sooo impromptu!"

Grok brushes off his shirt. "All is well that ends well. You got back just in time." He raises an eye curiously. "So, is this the right stream?"

Daisy shakes her head as she pulls off her helmet. Her long, curly blonde hair spills out and down her back, and she cricks her neck to relieve a bit of discomfort. "We're almost certainly in the wrong stream. This Jason is much too young. No sign of the one we're after."

"Mmm. Unfortunate." Grok reaches into the folds of his robe to pull out a small datapad, before tapping buttons and prompts on his screen. "So many universes to visit, but at least we have all the time in the, err, multiverse. Shall we try another one?"

"Yeah, I guess so. What else is there to do?" Daisy tosses her hands in the air, then pulls her foot back and taps her toes on the ground. "My feet are killing me. I hope the next universe has a nice spa, or something."

Grok steps behind her and rubs her shoulders gently. "We can take a few years off. Don't worry, my dear. Eventually, we will find the convergence point. It has to be out there somewhere."

Daisy nods and taps her arm panel a few times, pressing a little harder each time. "I know, I know. Next place we stop though, I need to do some maintenance. The damn suit keeps bugging out. Took me five seconds longer than it should've to get away from that one Jason." She frowns and stares at the wall as Grok rubs her shoulders. "I wonder what was up with the dark skin and the glowing tattoos."

"He saw you?" Grok raises an eyebrow, as Daisy sheepishly turns her head back to look at him.

"W-well, I kinda said... 'hi...'"

"Daisy..." Grok pulls his hands away and crosses his arms. "You know that could cause a split. Try and keep those interactions to a minimum."

"B-but, you...!" Daisy beckons to where Samantha departed. "You were just talking to that woman!"

"She isn't a Traveler. It's fine. Besides, I cannot allow a woman to carry such a weight on her shoulders alone. It will hurt my pride." Grok chuckles under his breath. "Let's go. There's no time like eternity."

"Right." Daisy sighs as she places the helmet back on her head. "Centurion, locate the next closest stream for me."

"ORDERS CONFIRMED, PILOT DAISY SOKOLOV."

Part 452c: Realization

A soft knock at the door. Three light taps, as always. At least she's predictable.

"Yes, you may enter, Rosalia." I finish buttoning up my long-sleeved undershirt just as she enters. Immediately, her eyes are drawn to my body, as expected. Every one of my muscles is chiseled to perfection, every facial hair diligently burned off three times a day, to ensure my face looks the same at all times. Unfortunately, the hair on my head can sometimes grow a little too much before I have it professionally cut, but such is life.

Rosalia's eyes turn away, averting from my unusual clothing. I'd ordinarily be slightly annoyed that someone was seeing me without my full suit on, but it's just the little twerp, after all. Her thoughts are of little consequence to me. The slacks and the undershirt will have to do in the mornings.

"I-I brought your suit, Mister Beelzebub, sir." Rosalia fidgets slightly as a worried look crosses her face. "But, um, please don't get mad or anything... there was a small accident while I was ironing them, and the, um, the iron overheated..."

My eyes narrow instantly. "Show me the damage."

Her hands shake as she carefully hands me my neatly folded jacket and pants. I unfurl the jacket and place the pants on the bed, staring for several moments as I examine yet another one of her mishaps.

"The b-burn isn't too noticeable, I hope..." The female wrings her hands together, even as she waits for me to verbalize my thoughts.

"This jacket is ruined. The second in only two days." Both of my hands clench the jacket's shoulders tightly as I stare at the lightly singed chest. "Do I ask too much of you?"

"No! Of course not, sir! I'm just, very clumsy... I didn't mean to, and I'll buy you a new suit-no, three new suits! You don't have to spend a dime!"

She's referring to human clothing, of course. While the designs for my outfits might be human in origin, the embroidering and stitching for them have always been performed by the most talented tailors among my people. Humans have no hand in making them, and I wouldn't wear such a suit if they did.

"No need. I will simply request another. I suppose I can't leave my room today since you have once more doomed me to wearing peasant clothes. I'd sooner die than be seen in public wearing such rags, especially if made by humans."

Rosalia bows her head. "You hate the humans that much? I mean, it's just clothing..."

"All things in life matter. If you hated humans a tenth as much as the average demon, let alone myself, you would understand. It's all about the principle. The failure of Diablo to crush the humans, and his subsequent fall at the fists of the human-loving Belial are proof that he is unfit to lead demonkind. Diablo considered the humans insignificant and thought it might be okay to ignore the vermin crawling out from under the rocks. He received a small punishment compared to his crime."

The younger demon looks at me in confusion. "Belial was the one who wounded Diablo? Where did you hear that?"

I resist rolling my eyes. "Obviously I have many sources. In any case, the fact that a human-lover was the one to give him the beating he deserved doesn't sit well with me. Belial is traveling to a tribunal where she will be forced to atone for her betrayal of the demons, but Diablo and Bael are out of commission. I suppose it will fall upon Mephisto's shoulders to lead the war effort... unless the First comes out of hiding."

"The First Emperor?!" Rosalia's eyes widen in awe. "B-but, he's never revealed himself! He could win the war all by himself if he wanted!"

"Possibly." I keep my voice neutral as I mull over the thought. "With his Second in command allying with a powerful angel and a human... the future has yet to be written. I often wonder if the First Emperor is the powerhouse everyone thinks him to be."

Rosalia scoffs, despite her lack of knowledge. "Of course he's unthinkable strong! If he can be at the top of the demons, he's practically a god compared to the humans!"

"I thought you liked the humans?" I raise an eyebrow at my younger peer. "It sounds like your allegiances are more blurred than you think."

She runs her finger across the hem of the pants lying on my bed. "It's not that I'm loyal to the humans or anything, I just think they're fairer. Humans help the weak, and they don't leave them to die, as the demons do. Don't you think that's a more compassionate way to treat others?"

It takes a mighty effort for me not to lose my composure and laugh in her face. "Compassion is a sign of weakness. You may choose to hug the enemy trying to impale you, but it will only lead to a skewered stomach. Demons breed strength, humans foster frailty. That is why demons rule the galaxy, while humans struggle to crawl out from under our thumb. They are inferior."

Rosalia's expression turns indignant. "But didn't humans hold all the power at one time? Demons were hiding in the shadows!"

"We turned the tides of war and defeated them. It was simple."

Her expression shifts again, this time to a frown. "They grew lax, considered us a non-threat, and we crushed them! That means the same could happen for them toward us now!"

Before I can offer a retort, I suddenly realize her words have a certain wisdom to them. This sudden realization fills me with many emotions and thoughts at once. "Hmm. Perhaps you are right. Diablo underestimated them, and it nearly cost him his life. The humans offer honeyed words, and a weapon impossible to defend against. Their ideas cannot be snuffed out by merely killing them, and may indeed grow strong enough to turn more demons to their side. Indeed, Belial and yourself are proof of that."

Silently, I turn away to look out my window at the human city beyond, where a sun shines down and warms its streets. A minute passes, as Rosalia's quiet breathing is the only thing audible in the room.

I understand, now. It is not the mechanical weapons of humanity that pose the biggest threat to demonkind, but their ideas and morals. For every demon the humans have killed, three more have spawned in their place. However, the contagion spreading throughout the Labyrinth is not one of death, but of weakness. The demons have yet to realize it, but the humans are infecting us with an illness that must be lanced before it festers into something more sinister.

If a demon fights a human, but doubts for even a second that slaying the human is the right action to take, it will be the last thing that whelp ever does. Worse still is the possibility of the demon laying down his weapons and joining the other side. A few thousand demons have already joined humanity, but what about when their numbers grow to ten thousand? A hundred thousand? Millions? At some point, it will be brother against brother, and we will lose not only the war of ideas but the war of blood as well.

"Mister Beelzebub, sir?" Rosalia's soft, inquisitive voice whispers to me, so I turn back to her.

"That is 'lord' Beelzebub to you, not 'mister.' Are we clear?"

"Y-yes, my lord."

"Excellent." I stare silently at the young demoness before me, evaluating her more carefully than I have in the past. Though drab and dull, without a hint of intelligence resting on the surface, the potential is there for her to become something more. At the least, she has inspired thoughts in my mind that I had never considered before.

Suddenly, a key clicks into place in my mind. A possibility I hadn't considered before.

Perhaps, with the First Emperor's appearance, more things have changed than I first thought.

"I will leave it to you to fetch a new suit for me from the tailor. In the meantime, I will simply have to wear this one today. It seems I have an experiment to perform."

"Huh?" Rosalia looks at me in bewilderment. "You're going to wear the suit anyway?! And what experiment? What do you mean?"

"We shall see. Begone, then, and make sure the next suit you bring me is in proper condition. I won't tolerate another flop from you."

As the young girl nods nervously and scurries out of the room, I snap my fingers to make a small flame appear in my hands.

"I wonder what the results of my little experiment will be?"

Part 453c: Stripped

The tribunal room stretches out before me, rising into a demonstone ceiling carved with the names of past and present lords, dukes, and emperors, alongside their likenesses. Torches made of gold and silver light up along the walls, illuminating the crowd of demons watching the proceedings, all of them seated in the back rows, listening silently to find out what schisms might emerge on this day in history.

Sitting silently before the Council is the Second Emperor, Belial. Among demons, she is the second strongest of our kind. If she were to face any other demon beside the First Emperor, she would win in a battle (most likely), and that alone is what gives her the power and prestige she has done so little to earn among demonkind.

As for showing up to her tribunal without donning any formal clothing, and still wearing her little whorish outfit... well, that's just what we've all come to expect.

"The Duke of Finances, President Ose, will be the primary judge for your tribunal, Lady Belial." Mephisto, the Duke of Mist gestures with his incorporeal hand toward me, and I nod slowly in return. "However, all four of us will have a say in what the results are of this inquisition."

Belial gazes up at us from her seat below. Ordinarily, the eight positions for the Council would be mostly filled up, but as the little bitch nearly killed the Third Emperor, and he had already gone mad and beat the daylights out of Bael, we're two members short. Belial would be another who might sit up here, and finally the First Emperor, though of course, we knew he wouldn't show up. He never does. All in all, only half the seats have occupants, but that condenses the power for judgment among four voices instead of eight, and none of us are pleased with her.

The look on the Second Emperor's face is solemn. "I understand. Let's get this over with."

Her blatant contempt for the court sickens me. It's bad enough that Belial is the only woman aside from myself among the upper-ranks of the demons, but she never takes an active role in leading her kind, leaving it to the men. She's a floozy who cavorts around, doing whatever she wants, while I have to do all the hard work. Worse still is her attitude and the way she carries herself, both of which are very unbecoming of a woman in power.

I lean over the bench to present her case. "Belial, you are on trial today for the attempted murder of the Third Emperor, Diablo, in the middle of an invasion against the humans, as well as the confirmed senseless murder of Gressil, Keeper of the Dungeons. Given that the oracles

have already divined the events and confirmed without a doubt that they are true, the question of whether these events did or did not happen isn't on the table today. Rather, this trial is to determine what your punishment should be."

Belial stares at me silently for a few moments before leaning forward and resting her arm on the table before her. "I understand."

Mephisto hisses under his breath. "Sss, yes, but also we must determine a motive. It is not unusual for demons to quarrel among each other in the lower ranks, even going so far as to kill their brothers and sisters, but the further up the ranks we go, the less acceptable such practices become. The point of the caste system is to breed strength among the lower ranks, which will then allow the strong to advance and earn their place in the middle and upper levels. Once a demon's power is acknowledged, further attempts to harm them are dissuaded."

Barbatos, the eldest of our kind, taps the desk to indicate he has something to say. "Even if it *were* true that we allowed demons of the upper ranks to compete among each other and kill one another to gain strength, which we do not, Belial's attack on Gressil had little to do with such matters. She attacked Gressil in a fit of rage, possibly to protect the human and angel she has grown fond of."

Hah, Barbatos is correct. Finally, the pathetic antics of the Second Emperor will be put to an end, today. It's bad enough that she's a worthless leader, and having a succubus as the Second Emperor demeans the position, but to allow our Second Emperor to assist the enemy forces outright? We should have taken her to trial *before* she had a chance to kill our most ruthless prison warden.

Better late than never, I suppose.

"Second Emperor, Belial, do you have anything to say in your defense?" Remembering the rules, I give her a chance to defend herself, as it would look one-sided in front of the lords watching from the back rows if we didn't give her a fair shot. Despite how much I dislike the woman, I won't stoop to her level and demean my position or abuse my authority.

She clears her throat, and her solemn expression turns contemplative. Who knows, perhaps she will say something intelligent for once?

"Humans are not evil, and they are not our enemies."

Oh. My hopes were too high.

She continues, "I have spent time with humans and demons alike, over my long life. When I was far younger, during the era of human rule, Satan would often send me to infiltrate human societies. I made love to human men, before plunging the knife into their backs, though usually

in a figurative sense. Satan effectively used me to secure demonkind's reach at the upper echelons of human society in absolute secrecy. However, in doing so, I began to change my views on them slowly. Most humans were petty and vain, and they fought for short-sighted goals due to their mortality, such as fame, personal fortune, and wooing the opposite sex. Despite this, I began to see that humans and demons were not as different as I thought, though I wouldn't dare say that to the demon I loved most."

Barbatos holds up a hand. "I was alive during those times, yet I do not recall you speaking your mind regarding your views. Did you fear the thought of having your title stripped? Do you mean to tell us that you have been a convert to the cause of the humans since before the Energy Wars?"

Murmuring in the back from the lords present make me glance behind the Second Emperor. These recent comments are only hurting her case, not helping. She might as well just admit she's a filthy human-lover and be done with it. At least then her punishment will be swift and precise.

"I'm not on the side of the humans, Barbatos. All I am saying is that their grievances with us are as justified as ours with them." Belial grits her teeth. "The humans in the Labyrinth are not the same as the ones we fought during and before the Energy Wars. Mortality has seen to that. These humans hate demons for oppressing them, feeding on them, and making them cower in terror every time demons appeared on their worlds to kill them and take soul energy. Surely, Barbatos, given you and Agares are as old as I am, and even more-so in your case, you can remember a time when demons cowered and hid from humans."

Barbatos smirks. He's not buying it. "Of course I remember. That is why humans deserve their lot in life. They scorched our kind and sent us hiding underground, so in return we now make them feel that same fear. If I didn't know any better, I'd assume you were saying we should let them off easy, after what they did to us."

Belial clasps her hands together on the table before her. "That isn't what I mean. I'm saying that since we once felt that fear, we know that it will not lead to anything but ever-escalating anger and hostility. If someone stabs you, then for the rest of your life you can choose to stab others to make them feel the same pain you once felt, or you can choose not to stab anyone else ever again since you don't want others to feel that pain. There are two paths the demons can take, and one of them will give us a short-term victory but an inevitable loss, while the other will bring us lasting peace."

"Peace." Agares, ever the silent one, speaks a single word, before reaching down to gently pet a giant crocodile beside him. "Such a concept does not exist for demons, nor will it ever exist for

any of the other sentients. The very fabric of demon society is built on conflict. First between brothers, then between comrades, and finally against our enemies. Conflict breeds strength, while peace stifles it. Even if the demons and humans truly wished to put the war behind us, it would never happen. We require their souls to mutate our power. As long as that is true, we will never not be at war with the fleshbags."

Furrowing her brow, Belial pounds a fist on the demonstone table, making the entire chamber rumble. "There are other ways! You haven't even considered them! Every time a human dies, their soul travels to the river Styx, and allows a demon to evolve! We don't need to kill them to use their power, we-"

Finally, I've had enough. "Belial! When was the last time you examined the Styx?! Did you not realize how thin it had grown before the First Emperor gave us the power to fight back? Have you been so busy cavorting with the humans that you paid no attention to the needs of your people?" Agares reaches over to touch my hand, perhaps to silence me, but I yank it away. "Humans take forever to die! The only way their natural deaths could sustain us is if we were to allow their population to grow out of control, and if that happened they would pose too big a threat! While you flirt with the human men and cast your responsibilities to the side, my job is to maintain order by giving mutations to those deserving, but our soul energy reserves have dwindled to almost nothing! Chaos is brooding in the Labyrinth, and YOU are one of the biggest reasons why!"

Belial scowls at me. "If we were at peace with the humans, then their population size wouldn't be a risk! Perhaps if we were to work with the Hero, we could find a way to-"

"Bollocks." Barbatos interrupts Belial and returns her nasty expression. "Humans are greedy. You said it yourself. Give a human a drop of water from your bucket, and they will kill you for the rest. If we were to try and make peace with them, they would eventually grow cocky, thinking they could take our lands from us. History corroborates this fact. Your ideas for peace have no basis in reality, and you know it. More importantly..."

The eldest demon trails off and looks up at the ceiling, with the images of demons past and present. "...I believe we now know the answer to this court's question. You plan to ally with the humans at any cost. You care little for the demons and only wish to have this one-sided 'peace,' which will allow you to sleep better every night alongside your new human lover. As such, it is clear that you killed Gressil because he threatened to take the angel back to the dungeon where she belongs, and you nearly slew Diablo because you don't care about the rest of us at all. In my eyes, you are a demon no longer. You are a corrupted human-lover, too far gone to be of value to our people."

It's all coming together now, my mind whispers happily. "The fact she didn't have the decency to heal Diablo after her attempted murder is proof that-"

The bitch interrupts me again. "I didn't attempt to *murder* Diablo. If I wanted him dead, I wouldn't have allowed him to crawl away. I certainly won't heal him in any case, because he hurt the man I love. He deserves to feel some pain."

Agares sighs and shakes his head. "And yet you healed the human afterward. You were willing to heal a human, but not a fellow demon. That speaks volumes to your convictions, and how you are no longer an ally of those present. I believe the court has made its decision, but the final judgment will be up to President Ose." The Duke of Reptiles gestures to me and leans back in his seat heavily, stroking his long, graying beard.

Barbatos and Mephisto whisper to each other for a minute, and while I can't make out what they're saying, it's quite apparent they're beyond disappointed in what they've found. Finally, Mephisto turns back to Belial. "I fought the human named Hero once, and I died at his hands. It was only the final sacred feather of the Phoenix that saved my life. To think that you would ally yourself with my killer, a human who has destroyed two planets and raised up an army of extermination, it angers me to no end. You have desecrated the memories of those who died in combat against the forces of the humans. I am certain President Ose will make the correct decision regarding how to handle you."

The eldest demon, Barbatos, doesn't say anything. He merely shrugs.

In the end, as expected, it's come down to me. "I will give you one last chance to speak, though at this point your fate is sealed. Have you any final words, Second Emperor?"

Slowly, she glances at all of our faces, then she gazes back at the crowd, before returning to the Council. "I believe you are making a grave mistake. Escalating this war will not serve to bolster demonkind up. Instead, it will bring us down. If maintaining the river Styx is one of your biggest goals, President Ose, then the only way to maintain it will be to send the lower ranks to die at the hands of the humans, which will cut down on its upkeep. Following this, the humans will find a way past the power of the First Emperor, and they will likely create some unthinkable superweapon, as they did during the Energy Wars. You will get your human souls, but in the end, they will win. I am not siding with the humans to upend the society we demons have built, but to protect it. I just wish you could take time to see things from their perspective."

Barbatos, coughs, having something to say. "You've conclusively admitted your belief that the humans will overcome our stranglehold on the Labyrinth. You are irredeemable."

"It's treason, then," Agares mutters under his breath.

Now that the dust has settled, I can allow a smile to creep onto my face. "My ruling is thus: Second Emperor, Belial. You are hereby stripped of your rank and banished from the Labyrinth. I hope never to see you again."

To my confusion, she smiles back. "I refuse to accept that verdict." The demons behind her gasp audibly, as she smirks and leans back in her seat.

Barbatos glares angrily at her. "What do you mean you won't accept it?! The law of this court is final! You cannot protest!"

As if she's been waiting for this the whole time, Belial fans out her fingers and examines her nails, as if she suddenly hasn't a care in the world. "The thing is, you don't have the power to banish me. I outrank you. Further, my rank is not merely a title. It is proof that I am powerful enough to kill everyone in this chamber with the slightest effort. That's the problem with a caste system based on meritocracy. I'm a better fighter than all of you combined. If you wish to strip me of my title and banish me, you'll have to use force."

Despite myself, my jaw drops. I never expected this, not from *her*. Belial has never asserted herself once in all the time I've known her. It takes a moment for me to form words. "Y-you! You can't just- that's not how this works! Why even show up to this court if you were going to make a mockery of it?!"

A strange look appears in her eyes. She sets her hand on the table and turns away, having examined her nails enough. "I spoke to an orc on the way here. He told me all the things you did, but somehow, the intent was different. I have the power to lead demonkind, but I lack the will. I lack the interest. I gained my power thanks entirely to Satan, and not because of my efforts. I've always just gone along for the ride. I deserve to be punished for that."

She pauses a moment. "But at the same time, while I do not deserve to rule, humans and demons must come to a reconciliation, or the next war we fight may be our last. There is something outside the Labyrinth, a menace that threatens all our lives. The ones who quietly rule over the Labyrinth in secret, the Volgrim, are fighting this danger silently, without telling us. While the demons focus on the humans, thinking only of the Volgrim as an annoyance, the Volgrim are faced with the possibility of their extinction. Once they're gone, we will be next, as will the humans."

Barbatos, his anger having faded, squints at her curiously. "This menace you speak of. What do you mean?"

"I suppose you don't know. I wonder if any here do." Belial shakes her head and sighs. "They're called Kolvaxians. I hadn't even heard of them until I traveled outside the Labyrinth with the human you all despise. They've ravaged Volgrim space, and they dominate the majority

of the galaxy. At the rate the war outside the Labyrinth is going, it won't be long before they're at our doorstep."

"Oh. Is that all?" Barbatos groans quietly and leans back in his seat, mirroring Belial. "After we press the humans back into their lairs, we will fortify the Labyrinth for this new menace."

"Exactly." Before Belial can try and worm more words in, I take the initiative. "In any case, even if we can't stop you, killing us will enrage the First Emperor and will turn all the demons against you. You don't have the authority here that you think you do."

"I'm *trying* to save lives, President Ose. Why don't you tell me how you *really* feel? It's apparent to everyone here that you have a personal vendetta against me, so I'll just apologize now for whatever I did to get you so riled up."

I'm not going to take her bait. "That doesn't matter. In any case, if you won't leave the Labyrinth with grace and dignity, we will have to summon the First Emperor, and he will pass judgment on you. After hearing the court's testimony, he'll make you wish you had chosen banishment."

Belial's gaze softens. "I wouldn't be so sure." Her words are quiet, just barely audible enough for us to hear. "The First Emperor is..." She pauses and looks away. "...I should speak to him, then. If you lot won't listen to reason, perhaps he will. Maybe I can finally tell him the truth."

"Huh?" I try to examine the mysterious color from her aura, but it's suddenly hard to tell what her emotions are. "You think knowing the First Emperor's identity while we don't gives you an advantage? Treason is still treason, and he couldn't deny that. I would take our sentence while you still can."

"I don't know who he is. He erases my memory every time I talk to him." Belial slowly stands up, exposing her barely covered body to all present. "I have a hunch. If I'm right, I could put an end to this war, and the four of you will be saved, even if you don't deserve it."

"We don't deserve- the nerve!" Mephisto hisses under his breath. "Worthlesssss... fine! Go and see the First Emperor, then! Use your succubus charm to save yourself! Cast yourself at his feet and do anything he tells you! I pray he uses you up and tosses you aside like the worthless whore you are."

A look of pain on Belial's face fills me with delight. Mephisto's words sting, and she can't hide it.

"I... I can't be like that anymore, Mephisto. That was the old me. I have someone else, now." The look of despondency on her face makes me quiver with joy, as she slowly turns and walks

out of the court. After she leaves, I sigh dramatically. "Have an Oracle follow her and ensure she visits the First Emperor. If she doesn't, we'll have to send an envoy instead."

Silence fills the court. Mephisto swallows carefully. "Um. Who would want to go? Diablo is out of commission..."

"I don't want to see the First Emperor... what if he kills me?" Agares turns white in the face at the thought.

Well, imp-shit. I didn't consider that much. "If you men are too weak, I'll do it. I'm sure after he casts Belial aside, he'll require a new queen at his side."

Barbatos leans forward to look past Agares. "Funny, after everything you said to the Second, I never took you for that kind of a woman."

Shut up. I'm a pragmatist.

Part 454c: Savior

"Jason? I'm going to the inner city for a bit. Want to come along?" I nudge the door to our room open and sigh, as I spot him sitting in a chair, with that board game in front of himself again. 'Chess,' as he calls it. The room is dark, despite it being the middle of the day, because he has the curtains pulled shut. Instead of using the electric light above, just a few candles illuminate the room.

"No, I'm just going to remain here for now," he says, moving a white piece before spinning the board around to play as the opposite color. I don't understand the appeal of playing a two-player game all by his lonesome, but then, I'm not interested in games.

Quietly, I rest my hands on my hips, lightly tapping my finger as I watch him stare at the board. "Moping around isn't going to bring Sammy back sooner. You should get some sunlight; it'll make you feel better."

"I feel fine, Cass." He's unusually curt, as he moves one of the smaller black pieces ahead two spaces and flips the board around. "I can't help feeling worried about Samantha. It's been four days."

"Uh-huh? She said it would be two weeks. The time to be worried is when it's been two weeks and a day."

"I guess so." He rests his finger on one of the pieces, just as Howard comes barreling around the corner.

"WARK! WARK!" Rushing over to me, Howard stumbles, smacks into the table, and several of the pieces on the Chess-board fall over.

Jason glares at the duck in annoyance. "Why don't you take the duck with you? He's getting on my nerves." As he picks up the pieces, he waves at Howard. "Shoo! Scram!"

"Jason! He's just an animal! He doesn't know any better!" A tinge of irritation enters my mind, but I stuff it back down. Jason's just troubled about Samantha, and he's taking it out on the closest creature he can see. He's a nice guy, but sometimes he can be distant. "C'mere Howard, come with mama."

Howard ignores Jason's anger and rushes over to me, poking at my feet cutely, as he always does. "Wark! Wark!"

I pick him up and cuddle him in my arms. "I'll see you later, Jason."

"You too, Cass." Jason forces a smile as I close the door. When I turn around, I squeak in fright, as Ionis appears behind me from out of nowhere, his iris staring right at the duck.

"Wark!" Howard quacks at the big robot, and I raise an eyebrow.

"You wanna come along too, Ionis? I'm just going to the city."

No response from the robot. He simply takes two steps back, clearing the path and allowing me to pass.

"Okay, then. You'd better be on your best behavior, then. No acting scary or attacking anyone, you hear?"

Again, no response, but he hasn't hurt a fly since I've known him, other than when he protected us from the Volgrim. He's a good robot, and even if Samantha and Jason don't trust him, I do.

I stroll past him, and the Sentinel falls into step beside me as we head for the palace entrance in the distance.

* * *

The sunlight beats down, warming my body as I stretch my wings out. Being indoors, as an angel, has the downside that my wings start feeling cramped after a while. It's like an instinct that I need to stretch and fly now and then or I start feeling depressed. I wonder if birds feel the same way?

After walking past the palace gates, I set Howard down and let him waddle along beside me. "Stay close, cutie. I don't want you getting stomped by people who don't see you."

"Wark." Howard quacks at me, though if he's saying anything, the meaning escapes me.

Only a minute later, I amble down the streets and start to notice an unusual pattern of people staring at me, and often at Ionis as well. To be fair, I barely ever leave the palace since I'm always sticking around Jason, but he constantly mopes around, ever since Sam left. I need to get some sunshine. The fact people haven't seen me before is apparent, as their expressions are a mixture of curiosity and awe.

I pause beside a merchant selling various fruits and vegetables. "How much for an apple, sir?"

He glances away from a customer on his left to look at me and takes a step back in surprise. "F-for you? The one who healed the troops? I'll give you a bushel for free!" He smiles hugely and starts to grab five or six apples to hand them to me, but I quickly shake my head.

"No no, that isn't necessary. I merely did whatever was within my power to save some lives. It's nothing. Treat me like you would anyone else."

His smile transforms into the same look of awe that others have been giving me. "So humble... what they say about you is true!"

Before he can say anything else, an older woman hobbles over on her cane. "Well, I'll be! It's the Divine Mother!"

I raise an eyebrow. "The who?"

"The Divine Mother! The last living angel! You saved the life of my boy, Peter. I owe you so much, and all I can do is pray to you nightly. I haven't a copper piece to my name." Indeed, the rags on her body attest to how poor she is.

"That's more than enough, ma'am. The thought you pray for me warms my heart." I offer her my sincerest smile, but she corrects me quickly.

"I may have misspoken, Divine Mother. I do not pray *for* you, but *to* you. It is the least we can do as citizens under your gentle rule."

I don't get a chance to question her about what she means. All of a sudden, half a dozen men and women shuffle a little closer to get a better look at me, and I begin to notice just how many people are in the town square today.

A mother walks past, carrying a basket of vegetables, and her young son follows behind her, holding a jug of water. He can't be more than eight years old. The boy comes to a screeching halt as he sees me. "Whoaa! Are you an angel?"

"What?" I smile politely at the boy, and Howard cranes his neck to see who's asking the question.

"An angel! I've heard the soldiers talk about them. They fly down and protect everyone with their big beautiful wings!"

I glance over at his mother, who looks horribly embarrassed, but I just smile at both of them. "That's right; I'm an angel. I'm the only one, though. The rest are gone."

The woman coughs into her free hand and reaches over to touch the boy's shoulder. "Now now, Alex, it's not nice to ask such personal questions."

"You're beautiful!" The boy looks past me at Ionis. "And that robot is cool too! Can it shoot lasers and stuff?!"

"Alex!" His mother swats him on the back, and the boy flinches, but his grin doesn't go away. "Be polite! Use your manners!"

A man in the crowd pushes through the others. "Divine Mother! I work for the Government as a commander on the frontlines! My son is sick with fever! Can you heal him with your divine powers?"

"My daughter is ill as well," says a woman from a few feet behind me. "She needs your blessing as well!"

"And my husband!"

Several people begin clamoring together, and suddenly I don't feel happy anymore. It's somehow disconcerting, having this many people hemming in on me. My breath- it's not coming as regularly as it was before. "Please g-give me a moment, just a little space..."

"Divine Mother! My family heirloom for a kiss! I love you!" A tall man tries to reach for me, but I stumble backward, barely escaping his grasp.

I'm disoriented... so many people! This was a bad idea. I shouldn't have come into town without Jason! I don't know what to do!

A moment later, an ominous humming sound fills the area and everyone freezes. The air itself vibrates intensely, as if it were caused by the rumblings of something deep below. A second later, I realize Ionis is the source. He takes a menacing step forward, and the crowd leaps back in fright as all their eyes jerk up to his enormous, overwhelming presence.

As if by magic, the crowd scatters, several people bowing politely, others scurrying off, trying to get away. Ionis didn't have to use a single weapon, and he made sure in an instant they knew who was boss.

My pounding heart slows down, and my breathing returns to normal, as the only person left is the merchant from before. He stares up at Ionis, his lip quivering slightly. "That's some robot you got there. I felt every bone in my body tellin' me to run, but I was so damn scared I couldn't. Is it your bodyguard?"

"Um, bodyguard? Sure, something like that. Haven't you seen a Sentinel before?" I feel my shoulders sag a little bit, as the tension from before melts away.

"Never heard of them. Are they a new model? He looks like he could tear some demons apart." The man wipes his forehead, and relaxes a little as well. Evidently, he's realized Ionis won't hurt him.

"Well, he certainly could. Of course, I try to make sure that doesn't happen. I don't like fighting or war. I'm trying to put an end to the demon-human conflict right now, in fact."

"Oh." The shopkeeper stares at me blankly. "I, err, I thought you smote thousands of demons on the battlefield? The rumors going around say you healed our army with your right hand, and

slew demons with your left."

I try not to show a visible reaction but probably fail. "Rumors aren't always accurate. I've never hurt a demon in my life, and I'd prefer not to start now."

"Well, you'd best let the local pastors know, then. They've been preaching about how you'll end the war against the demons with the help of the God-King."

My eyes narrow immediately. "What *else* are the pastors saying?"

The shopkeeper suddenly looks a little bashful. "Well, it's said that the God-King created you in his image, as his ultimate weapon of the light. There's even a prophecy that alongside the Second Emperor of the demons, the three of you will be the instrument of our salvation and lead us to a new age of prosperity, with the demons as our servants, to be forever punished for their crimes."

Silently, I seethe on the inside. Outwardly, I give the man a big, cheerful smile. "Wow! Those are some *great* prophecies! Where's the nearest church? I need to talk with those pastors as soon as possible."

Reaching for an apple, the shopkeeper tosses me one. "This is on me. I don't get to talk to angels very often, you know. The local church is just up the street, walk four blocks, take a right. You won't be able to miss it."

"Thank you, sir. You've been a wonderful help, Mister...?" I trail off, realizing I don't know his name.

"Oh, my name is Zhao. I'm just a humble man trying to make a living." He pauses for a moment, before that sheepish look resurfaces. "Say, before you go, perhaps you have some words of wisdom? They say angels are the wisest creatures among the ancient races."

Uh oh. I'm not even that smart, let alone 'wise.' The man's eager gaze as he clasps his hands together only fill me with dread.

Come on, say something wise and smart-sounding. You're the last angel, Cass! If you act like an idiot, everyone will think less not just of you, but of all angels in the past as well!

My mind screams at me for what feels like ten minutes, but is probably more like two seconds, until I take a deep breath, calm down, and reach inside myself. I don't have to be wise. Many came before me that shared their knowledge freely, and some of those memories are still within me.

Think. When I was a little girl, what did I learn in Sunday School? I learned words of wisdom from the holy book of my time. A man once walked the Earth who was also the most almighty archangel of them all. What would he say in my shoes?

Ah, now I know. Pausing, I smile sweetly at the man. "When someone hurts you, turn the other cheek. An eye for an eye leaves both participants sightless, but an act of kindness can turn an enemy into a lifelong ally."

My stomach roils as I try my damndest to keep my composure. I hope what I said wasn't something Zhao's heard before, but perhaps there's a chance he hasn't and-

"Ah! I see!" Zhao nods slowly, scratching his chin as his eyes cast downward. "The demons have harmed us many times, but if we return the pain we've felt, we will only continue the cycle of violence. Is that what you mean?"

He... he gets it! Zhao understands what I've been saying all along! My heart leaps for joy, even though I keep my expression neutral. It takes a monumental effort, but I manage to hold myself with dignity and poise.

"Precisely. I wish you the best, and offer a blessing for your shop. May your wares sell well, Zhao."

The two of us slightly bow to each other, and I continue on my merry way, walking up the street toward the church. I've learned a lot today, and all of it has been distressing. The fact people are praying to me makes me feel uncomfortable. Prayers should be given to great gods and angels who have accomplished incredible things. Compared to them, healing a few thousand people is nothing. Besides, Samantha helped out a bunch, and she barely got any of the credit!

"Oh! You're the pretty lady!" The little boy from earlier, Alex, bounds up to me, a skip in his step. "Mum pulled me away, but I wanted to see you again. Will you marry me?" The boy thrusts his hand forward, and in it is a small flower with yellow petals.

"M-marry you? Oh, you're adorable!" I quickly glance around, happy that there's nobody nearby for once. Leaning down, I give him a quick kiss on the cheek. "I already have a man in my life, but I'm sure there's a pretty girl out there who likes you."

"Y-you think so?" Alex rubs his cheek slowly and takes a step back, staring at me in admiration. "There is this girl I know..."

"Oh, splendid! It sounds like you already have someone in mind." I wink knowingly at him, only to realize he isn't smiling anymore.

"Susie Miller. She goes to my church. Vanished a couple of days ago, she did. Nobody knows where she's run off to."

"Oh. I'm sorry to hear that." I suddenly feel awkward, and the boy's expression isn't helping. "Is anyone looking for her?"

Slowly, he shakes his head. "Uh-uh. I tried, but mum needs me to help around the house. Everyone says she must've gotten lost, but I know better'n that."

"What, uh, what do you think happened to her?" I ask the question cautiously, noticing he's much quieter than he was a few minutes ago.

"Um. Well, I sorta... I think a demon took her. One of the demons let loose by the king."

"From the work camps?"

"Mm-hmm." Alex taps his foot on the ground quietly and crosses his arms. "Bloodskins are always up to no good."

"Hey! Don't talk about demons like that. I'll have you know my best friend is a demon, and she's very nice." I wave my finger in his face chidingly, but also pull back and sigh. "That being said, there are plenty of bad ones. Any idea which demon it was?"

Alex shakes his head and taps his lip. "Susie said she'd made friends with one, but wouldn't tell me anything else. I told her to keep her distance, but she didn't. I'm worried about her. The adults don't care. Even the people at the orphanage she lived in don't care."

Nobody cares about her. His words echo in my mind. Memories of being trapped in total darkness, a demon tormenting me every time I was about to break, always keeping me on the edge of sanity, and the realization nobody cared enough to save me... they come back to me all at once. The agony of being too weak even to end my life, too frail to bite my tongue, and the knowledge it wouldn't have worked anyway. I... I wouldn't wish that on my worst enemy.

Somewhere, there might be a girl being held captive by a demon... or worse. At the least, if I don't look for her, nobody else will. I have to find out what happened. It won't sit right with me if I don't. How can I call myself a protector of the innocent if I can't help one little child?

I glance in the distance at the church. *Another day.*

"Okay, Alex, when did your friend go missing? I need to know more details."

* * *

The Volgrim commander's face is admirably stoic, but in light of the news, it's apparent he's just putting up a veneer of strength. "Holvarius has been taken over by the Kolvaxians. The surprise attack gave us no time to react. Within a single hour, the spores rained down and corrupted all life until our forces in orbit were forced to flee."

The only look I can give him is a solemn one. "Holvarius is only a hundred light-years from the center of Volgrim space. We've lost one hundred billion members of our species, and they've gained as many converts. This is the worst scenario."

"I apologize, Elder Basil. The fault was entirely mine. I wish my apologies could undo my failure." Commander Korvas bows, his holographic image projecting the motion to the entire Council watching.

"I could hardly blame you, Commander Korvas. As the highest strategic leader of the military, it was my duty to protect the inner worlds with sufficient forces. At the least, can you..." I pause, feeling a great heaviness resting on my shoulders. "...can you provide us with details of the attack? How were they able to overwhelm our defenses? Their military capabilities should have been well within our ability to counter. The warp-gates would have ensured we could deliver reinforcements within the hour of their arrival. I cannot fathom how they accomplished so much in a single hour."

Commander Korvas dabs his forehead with a dry cloth. "There was a capital ship among their forces that we hadn't seen before. It wasn't one of our captured machines, and it was decidedly not of Volgarian make. The inside was hollowed out and housed a colossal swarm of small drone ships, all of which surrounded the planet so that none could escape. The ship must have been tens of kilometers long. I've not seen anything like it since..."

The commander trails off, but I understand what he means. "Not since the Energy Wars? Hm. I wonder where the Kolvaxians got their hands on such a ship. In any case, we can't afford to mope around. They're within striking distance of the core systems. If we can't come up with a counter-measure, they're going to wipe us out."

Pausing, I steal a glance over at Elder Lozu. "I suppose the anti-war faction would prefer we hug it out? A hundred billion Volgrim have been corrupted by the Kolvaxian plague. Now is not the time for weakness. We must bring the doomsday research back online if we hope to stop them before it's too late."

Elder Lozu pales as the court turns toward him. He is far from alone in his opinions, as a third of the members present believe that war with the Kolvaxians is folly, but he is the leader, and thus he shapes the opinion of his peers. At the least, I can give him credit for his influence. Few Volgrim of such youth can rise to the level he has in such a short span of time.

His fingers rap on the desk. "It isn't that my faction dislikes the idea of going to war. We simply disagree with the measures you're suggesting. Full-scale annihilation is forbidden by the ancient texts, and bringing that research back to the light would mean desecrating the graves of the Founders themselves! Furthermore, it was buried for a reason. The temptation to use that knowledge is so great that we might be inclined to use the weapons for more than just protecting our existence."

"You think we would use the old technology for civil wars and infighting? Preposterous!" I scowl at my younger peer, as his typical impishness shines through. "The Volgrim have known for eons now that fighting among ourselves will not lead us anywhere productive. Words will solve conflicts better than weapons will, at least among ourselves. This enemy is unlike any we've faced before. If we could recreate the Sentinels, but without their flaws, we could wipe these monsters out before it's too late! You saw what just a single Sentinel did to half our reserve fleet!"

Lozu balls his hand into a fist and pounds the table. "And what if the new weapons are defective like the old?! Not only would we have the Kolvaxians at our doorstep, but a new breed of Sentinels tearing us apart from within! Even if they were completely loyal to their creators, there would still be the possibility the Kolvaxians corrupt the new machines as well! Better to use tried and true weapons of war than experimental, untested weapons with a high chance of backfiring!"

My teeth grind together, nipping the insides of my mouth with their sharp edges. "You... you have to understand... war means taking risks! You cannot win a war by playing it safe!"

"So you would detonate a bomb at our feet in the hopes that shrapnel takes out the enemy? That's not a risk; it's suicidal!"

The two of us glare at each other before I shove away, rubbing my belly in disgust. This is how the discussion always ends. Without a unanimous vote approving their use, we cannot unlock the old archives.

Many thoughts come to mind. *Perhaps I could send a crew to the original Volgarius homeworld in the hopes of finding information about the Sentinels. Where one Sentinel exists, a way to make more should be possible...*

Bah! Even if I do, Lozu is right that the original Sentinels rebelled. We need to start from new foundations, not build off the old. It's a waste of time!

As always, we're no further to a resolution than we were before. Perhaps I should take the advice of one of my fellow councilmembers, who told me to flee to the nearest galaxy. It's unlikely the Kolvaxians have spread to Andromeda. The Volgrim could make a new life there, and leave the old behind.

We'll just have to keep the option on the table.

Commander Kolvas clears his throat. "Regarding the refugees from Holvarius... there aren't many, but they should be resettled at once."

"Yes, yes... Elder Lozu can attend to that matter." Gleefully, I push the work onto him and smile, even as that same feeling of darkness enters my mind once more.

We're losing the war. If we don't come up with something, and soon, there won't be a Volgrim species left in the universe.

Part 455c: Investigation

Queen moves from E1 to E4. Black's turn. Bishop moves from F4 to H6, retreating from the sudden appearance of the queen. It's a trap. How should White respond? Obviously, since I'm playing both sides, I can't fall into my own trap, but how do I go about avoiding it? Perhaps if I-

My thoughts are put on hold as the bedroom door creaks open, and a weary Cassiel strolls in, sighs dramatically, and flops face-first on our bed to my right.

Quietly, I glance over and evaluate her condition. She's exhausted. "Hey, Cass. Been having fun? I haven't seen you in a couple of days."

Honestly, I was starting to get worried. I used *Locate* a few times and determined she was traveling all over the city but didn't appear to be in any distress. I'm not her father, so if she needs a day off from me, she can have it. After the way I talked to her last time, I thought maybe I pissed her off, and she didn't want to come back.

"I'm sooo tired..." Cassiel mutters, her mouth embedded in the covers. I can barely make the words out. "I just can't solve the mystery."

I reach over from my little table and squeeze her shoulder. "You doing okay? I thought maybe you were mad at me or something. It seems you've been off having an adventure."

Her wings twitch for a moment before pushing on the bed and spinning her face-up. She gazes up at the ceiling, then closes her eyes and breathes lightly. "There has been a recent series of murders and disappearances in the city. Humans and demons alike. I can't find the culprits."

"Murders?" My calmness vanishes. "What do you mean?"

Cassiel folds her hands and rubs them together for a few moments. "This little boy asked me to look for one of his friends. Her name is Susie. I didn't find her. Instead, I found out that one of the local militia had his throat cut open during a night patrol. Then, I found out that two women in the information branch went missing at the same time. I started to notice that a few demons were reported missing, and just yesterday a demon girl was found hung with a noose, her hands tied behind her back, in her home. I'm disgusted."

"That's awful." I keep my tone neutral, but secretly I'm nervous. Did nobody bother to tell me? Does the King even know? What the hell is going on? "You didn't find any leads, Cass?"

"Not really. The only thing the murders have in common is that most of them happen late at night. The abductions are all over the place."

I narrow my eyes. "But you're sure they *are* abductions, right?"

She squirms. "Err, well, no... I can't prove that. It's just a hunch."

Turning my gaze away, I look back at the chessboard. "Anything could be happening. This could be humans killing other humans, then still others blame the demons and lynch them, or demons could be the culprits, or perhaps a mixture of both. I know there's still some anti-demon sentiment in the city, but to think either side would go so far..."

Cassiel swallows audibly. "Well, I've talked to demons and humans alike. Both blame the other for the murders and disappearances. The demons I spoke to claimed the humans were killing demons because of irrational fear and paranoia, while the humans claimed the demons were murdering humans and their fellow demons because... well... because demons are animals with no morality."

"Sounds like both sides are running scared," I say, heaving a great sigh.

I crawl on the bed and gently lay on Cassiel's wing beside her, pushing my hands under my head to stare up at the ceiling as well. "Are you doing okay, Cass? It sounds like you're taking these murders to heart. They aren't your fault, you know."

As I expected, Cassiel sighs intensely and opens her eyes. "I mean, of course, they aren't my fault... but people have stopped looking at me as a person. They're treating me like a perfect arbiter of justice. Everyone expects me to solve these murders, but I don't know what I'm doing!" She pauses and clutches her chest. "Shoot, everyone I spoke to had some question they wanted me to answer or some wisdom they expected me to dole out... one man even wanted me to choose the punishment for a thief who stole from his shop. I don't know how to do any of that stuff..."

Cassiel is having a rough time. I gaze at the ceiling silently, thinking about how selfish I've been over the last few days. I can't stop thinking about Samantha and worrying about her getting into trouble or whatever the sentence will be for her behavior. While I've been thinking about her, Cassiel's been out on her own, dealing with expectations she can't handle yet. I remember when I created this city, and I had no idea what I was doing. I tried to make a working monarchic government, and I suppose I succeeded, but my stupid actions sparked a war inside the Labyrinth.

I've been trying to deal with the repercussions of my choices as a leader, and Cassiel is quickly being shaped by public opinion into a role she isn't ready for. It's no wonder Cass is distressed. She's in the same position I was just a few months ago.

"I wish you'd asked me sooner, Cass. I'd have helped you track down whoever's causing trouble. You didn't have to go at it alone."

She doesn't respond, and when I turn to look at her, I spot tears in her eyes. "J... Jason..."

Jerking up in the bed, I turn to look at her. "What?! Was it something I said? I'm sorry!"

She looks away and wipes her eyes with her arm. "No, it's- it's not that. I'm just glad that you care. Every time I think about someone hurting that little girl, it makes me sick on the inside. It reminds me of what Gressil did to me, and then everyone expects me to be strong and wise, but I'm an idiot! I don't know what I'm doing at all! If I can't even help one little girl... I'm worthless."

Jesus. I didn't realize just how much all of this was affecting Cass. Reaching over, I grip her hand in mine. "The fact you went out to help everyone but didn't think to ask me for help proves that you're coming out of your shell, Cass. I'll help you now, but you shouldn't insult yourself like that. Not many people could go through what you have and stay relatively whole as a person, let alone be so kind and forgiving. If it had been me in that prison cell, I'd probably have snapped long ago. You have to look at your strengths, not your weaknesses. That's what everyone else is doing; you just don't see it yet."

She snuffles, so I create a handkerchief and give it to her. After she wipes her nose, she sighs again. "Thanks, Jason. I don't know what I'd do without you."

I snicker under my breath. "Evidently you'd try and solve a mass murder on your own. Your problem is that you think I'm smart, but don't realize I'm pretty dumb too. I've made a lot of mistakes over the last ten years I spent in the Labyrinth, and I'll continue to screw up. Once you realize that nobody has any idea what the future holds, you can stop judging yourself so harshly."

Cass doesn't smile back. "I'm serious. If it weren't for you, I wouldn't have the energy to heal thousands at once, I wouldn't have a role model for what it means to be a leader, I'd be all alone in a foreign world I didn't understand, and none of that would matter anyway, since I'd still be locked up. Without you... I'd be nothing."

I can't respond. My brain locks up, as I gaze at her beautiful form, lying on the bed. Her eyes meet mine, and I feel a deep sadness mixing with a profound happiness. Specters from her past may always haunt her, but she's working every fiber of her body to improve herself. What have I been doing for these last few days? Moping around and playing chess in a poorly lit room? How can I be worried when I barely know the meaning of suffering? If Cassiel can have such a sharp mind after everything she's been through, I have no excuse.

"Hey, Cass. Let's go and find that murderer, together."

Her eyes widen slightly. "Really? You want to help? But what about, erm, Samantha? Weren't you going to play Chess until she-"

"Pff, it's just a stupid board game." I quickly wave off her concerns and tug her hand, pulling her into a sitting position. "I'd rather help you out than mope around like some loser. Come on, with my Wordsmithing and your incredible intellect; we can crack this case wide open, Doctor Watson."

Cassiel's innocent gaze shifts as her eyes narrow. "Are you mocking me?"

"Nope." I smile sweetly and lean in, kissing her softly. "I could never make fun of you. I love you too much."

Blushing, she rubs her wing that I was laying on to stir some feeling back into it. "Yeah, I know. Thanks, Jason."

"Anything for you, Cass."

* * *

"Mister Beelzebub, sir! Hello!" A voice from the door makes me roll my eyes. And here I was hoping this would be the one day she wouldn't drop by. Quickly, I compress the clothes inside my suitcase and zip it up, hiding it under the bed. While I'm not fond of human creations, the function of the 'zipper' is quite fascinating to me. I wonder how the humans thought to make the little pins click in and out of place when the metal flap pulls up and down? Perhaps I've missed a few areas where humans deserve some praise, but those are few and far between.

Once my suitcase is hidden, and I've pulled the covers down to hide it, I groan inwardly. "Yes, Rosalia, you may enter." The young demoness steps inside and her outfit makes me scrunch my face up. "What is that dress?"

"Hmm? This thing? I found it on sale at a flea market! Isn't it pretty?" She pirouettes and allows the red dress, with its many folds and frills to fan out. While indeed it is a 'cute' dress, especially for a precocious young thing like her, it's also *gaudy*.

"Of *course* you'd purchase such a thing from a place riddled with fleas." I curl up my lip in disgust. "You should stick to maid outfits. They suit you better. That scarlet fabric looks like something a spoiled bratty princess would wear."

Immediately, she stops spinning and stares at me, a look of awe on her face. I can almost swear I see stars in her eyes. "M-mister Beelzebub, sir... you think I look like a princess?"

"No! That isn't what I said!" Before I can protest further, she spins around again, clapping merrily about my '*praise*.' She's an absolute airhead.

"Beelzebub thinks I'm pretty! Hooray!" She stops suddenly and blushes. "If you think I'm pretty, then does that mean you'd take me as a mate?"

Guh. I can hardly contain my disgust. "Certainly not. I care more about power and prestige than I do such pathetic trifles as 'love.' Besides, humans mate to produce offspring, but only Broodmothers can create imps, so there's no point aside from formality and combining the power of two demons. Since you lack any semblance of prestige or power, I'd never consider it."

"Oh..." Her happiness deflates as depression takes hold. The moment barely lasts as another enthusiastic smile appears. "So if I become a mighty demon, you'd take me as a mate?"

Her question gives me pause. "Well, you are rather plain-looking. Even if Belial herself wished for such a privilege, I'd refuse on principle." Another second passes as I examine her. "Have you grown taller?"

Rosalia twirls her finger around a ribbon wrapped around her waist. "Well, um, actually..."

I glance down and notice something else. "New shoes. Designed to increase your height, I presume. The sort of falsification I've come to expect from human clothing."

Her expression lights up. "Human clothes are wonderful! You should think more highly of them!"

"I'd say they're more along the lines of 'tacky.' In any case, why did you come to bother me? I'm quite busy."

"Why *did* I?" She taps her lip for a moment before remembering the reason. "Oh! I wanted to ask if you were busy next week! There's a festival in the city and I, um..." She suddenly freezes as a look of guilt crosses over her face. "W-well, I wanted to know if you would, err, that is- if you'd like to come with me..."

Oh, seven devils. It's like that, is it? "You want me to go with you to the festival?"

"Well, um, you don't have to..." She lowers her head to stare at my feet. "I guess I'm not pretty enough for you."

"You've got that right." Grumbling to myself, I decide I might as well come clean. I reach under the bed and pull my suitcase out. "I'm leaving this city and returning to the Labyrinth. My recent experiments have proven very fruitful, and now I have a path to embark upon. I doubt we'll ever see each other again."

"What?! You're leaving?" Her voice strains as she stares at the suitcase. "B-but why? Why would you leave? I thought you were stuck here!"

"I thought the same too, but that's what my experiments have proven. I'm freer than I originally thought, and I have a goal now, something to work toward. As for yourself, you can stay behind. You were barely adequate as a housekeeper, and I won't require your services any longer."

My quick dismissal renders her unable to speak. I grab the suitcase from my bed, and she gawks in silence as I push past her. If only she'd come ten minutes later, she wouldn't even know where I was going. So much for a stealthy exit.

Before I can reach for the door handle, she grabs at my jacket sleeve. "Wait, Mister Beelzebub! I don't want you to go! I..." She stammers for a moment before continuing. "...I love you! I don't care if you don't like me at all! I don't care if you won't return my feelings! Can't I stay by your side? I'll follow you anywhere!"

I quickly yank my arm away and scowl. "Absolutely not. You speak above your position. Having you around will make me look weak and ineffective, and that is not the impression I wish to project. Not after what I'm about to do. Stay here, and live among the humans. It's all you're good for."

The young girl stares up at me, tears in her eyes. "How can you be so cruel...?"

"Cruel? If you think my honesty is 'cruel,' then you haven't an idea what lies in wait for you in the game of life. You're pathetic, and as long as you stay like that, nobody will ever care about you. Goodbye, Rosalia."

I step through the door and leave the insect to cry and wallow in misery in her room. As I thought, if my dismissal had this much impact on her, she'd be worthless for my plans.

And *what a future* it's going to be.

"Heh heh heh..." I chuckle as I stroll outside.

Goodbye, humans. Hello, glory.

Part 456c: The Clone Wars

"Sorry mister Hero, sir, I ain't know nothin' 'bout no kid." The middle-aged man tosses his hands up and thumbs his finger back at the church behind him. "The abbey runs an orphanage on the side, but they only gots a dozen kids 'r so."

Cassiel nudges me aside. "What about a man named Lorence? I hear he went missing two days ago. Do you know anything about him?"

The man frowns and screws up his face. "Mmm, Lorence? He's an old fart, ain't he? In his seventies, I reckon. Barely got outta the house, only came to church once a month. He done gone missing too?"

"Yes." Cassiel nods sadly. "So you say he was infirm? Not very strong?"

"Just about, Divine Mother. Lorence'd lose in a fight to a toddler, haha!"

I thank the man and pull Cassiel away as we head to the church. "Cass, have you noticed a pattern with the victims yet?"

She shakes her head. "Other than the time of day, not really. Have you?"

"Yeah. I have yet to hear of one person going missing who was in the prime of their life. It's always kids and old people. You know, those who are weak and defenseless."

Cassiel's eyes widen. "Oh! You're right! So that means whoever's abducting them is-"

I interrupt her. "We don't yet know these are abductions. Let's not jump the gun."

"Oh, right. Sorry." She blushes slightly. "Well, in any case, *if* they're being abducted, someone is targeting them because they need easy prey. What about the demon victims? Any thoughts?"

"I don't know enough, yet. Might be a vigilante, might be a false trail to throw us off the human victims, and it might even be a series of coincidental suicides. Tough to say. Only three demons have been murdered so far, so compared to the dozen humans; I'd say they're a lower priority for now."

"Huh?" Cass looks miffed. "A lower priority? Just because they're demons?"

"No, Cass, because there are only three victims. The humans are still being targeted, but the demon-killer is inconsistent." I shake my head as we stroll into the church. "Of all people, I'll be the last one to ignore demons as victims *just* because they're demons."

"I hope so," Cass says, seeming unusually reserved as I push the doors open.

The church is empty right now, as it's not a day for worship. A single man in black robes quietly walks around, pushing a broom back and forth as he cleans up his floor. When he hears the door open, he looks up at us. "Sorry, but the church is closed for cleaning and- oh!" The instant he spots Cassiel, his visage changes. "The Divine Mother! My word!"

I'm a little annoyed he doesn't mention me, but as he jogs over to us, his smile widens. "And the God-King himself! It is my greatest pleasure to welcome both of you to my church! I am Father Matlock, but you can call me Morgan if you please!"

Morgan Matlock, huh? Pale skin, a giant bald patch on top of his head, and so many freckles on his cheeks it's a little absurd. He's harmless. Might be helpful for our investigation, though.

Cassiel bows and smiles sweetly at him. "Father Matlock, I've been looking forward to meeting you. I've heard... *many rumors* about your church and the things you teach here."

His church isn't anything special. Wooden benches, a generic symbol of some random bird above the pulpit... heck, for me, it even feels a little weird. Being in a church without Jesus on a cross isn't something I'm used to, let alone how familiar crosses are to me. Sometimes I forget just how foreign the culture in the Labyrinth is, compared to how I grew up.

Morgan nods excitedly. "Yes, yes! I've been spreading the word about your heroic deeds throughout all of Hero City! The Divine Mother, capable of blasting the demons back to the darkest pits of Hell with one hand, and bringing the dead back with her other! Your tales will erupt like wildfire as people preach the good word to their friends and neighbors."

My girlfriend smiles again, but this time barely concealing a small level of annoyance. "Well, about those teachings. Um, you see, I wanted to ask you some questions about a few missing people, but I also wanted to... correct a few things you've been teaching the flock."

It takes a moment, but Morgan's eyes widen in horror. "Oh, goodness! Have I missed your more impressive deeds?! Have I failed to inform enough people of the lives you've saved? Say the word, my lady, and I will cast myself onto a sword in your honor!"

It's at this moment that I realize an awful truth. *This guy's a zealot. A fanatic zealot. Cass doesn't know what she's gotten herself into.*

"No, no, that isn't necessary! Actually, you've exaggerated a few things a little too-"

"Is this regarding the Seven Virtues?!" Morgan's eyes slam shut and he pounds on his chest. "I beg your forgiveness! I thought that if I gave your figure a few faults, people would have something to aspire to! I will remove them from the record at once. Everyone will know you are the perfect Mother to watch over us all."

Cassiel's face contorts as she desperately forces a grimace down and manages to keep smiling. "No! No, that isn't necessary at all! I simply haven't done the things that you've claimed. I didn't kill any demons. I'd never do such a thing, for I despise war and violence."

Father Matlock opens his eyes and stares at her in confusion. "But, the archdemon, Bael! And the Ancient Deity of Supreme Evil, Diablo! I heard you smote them out of existence with a blast of divine light! Were the soldiers wrong? Have they lied to me?!"

"That wasn't me, I'm afraid. That was actually-" Cassiel pauses, glancing back at me.

Wait, is she seriously thinking I don't know it was Samantha who beat the living shit out of Diablo? I thought we went over this!

It occurs to me that I never outright said I knew, but Cass seems dead-set on not telling me what happened. "Okay, you got me there. I didn't kill Diablo, though! I just weakened him and sent him scurrying away."

Morgan nods, his mouth hanging agape. "Ah! I see, now. So the error lies in my underestimation of your beautiful forgiveness of your foes! How wonderful, how saintly! To spare thy enemy to convert them to thy cause, you must be a most kind and forgiving Divine Mother. I have made you out to be a murderous monster, but in truth, you wish only for love and peace upon the world!"

Cass gnaws at her lip and shoots another glance at me, but I can't read her expression. "Well, that's a little more accurate, I guess. I'm certainly going for more of the 'peaceful' aspect than-"

"Wonderful! Blessed be your name! I shall preach your will from the highest mountains and the tallest buildings! By day's end, this new guidance will become doctrine in our church. Anything for you, my lady!"

Finally breaking down, Cassiel just scowls. "Yeah, I suppose that works."

The Father doesn't notice her irritation. "Splendid, just splendid! What else can I do to help the God-King and the Divine Mother?"

Deciding Cassiel is suddenly not in the right mood to be talking to him, I gently pull her a little behind me. "Perhaps you can assist us with one other thing. There have been a series of disappearances lately. A little girl named Susie vanished in the middle of the night, as well as an older man named Lorence, and several other people. About a dozen, by my count. Do you have anything that can give us a lead? Even the smallest detail can help us find them."

Morgan's expression deflates. Darkness shrouds his face. "Ah, them? They're dead, I'm afraid. Quite dead."

His sudden change in expression chills me. "How do you know that? Do you have proof?"

He nods slowly. "Indeed, I do. Members of my flock found the bodies. Mutilated, chewed up, and their throats were always scorched with fire, as if someone had plunged a torch down their gullet. Susie was the first... we found her in a dark alley, not ten blocks from here. Lorence, Jedediah, many others were slain in their homes. Obviously, the culprit was a demon."

I evaluate his countenance for a moment or two. He isn't lying. Silently, I probe his mind with my telepathy, something I try my hardest not to do, but I have to be sure, this time. Images of the mutilated bodies appear in my mind, instantly sickening me.

After pulling out of his thoughts, it takes me a moment to force the images out of my memories. "You aren't lying. Why kill those people?"

Cassiel bows her head, and when she speaks, her teeth grit together. "It's like Samantha said. Demons kill humans to gather soul energy for themselves. There must be a killer in this city secretly powering himself up."

"Disgusting." I nearly spit the word out. "Humans give demons their trust, and this is how they repay us? Why would a demon turn on those who sheltered him? They must hate humans in a way no other could, to be that low."

Father Matlock nods silently. "Aye. While other humans may be willing to give demons a chance, many of us remember the Old Ways. Never turn your back on a demon, lest they take the chance to give it a good stabbing."

From the corner of my eye, I spot Cassiel glaring at the Father. "Hold on a second. Do you mean to tell me that you've been turning vigilantes against the demons? Is that why three of them were found murdered?!"

The Father blanches. "N-no, certainly not! I had nothing to do with that! I would never hurt anyone!"

Cassiel's anger evaporates. "I suppose not. You'll just proselytize in the hopes that someone else would. It seems to me that we have an anti-demon assassin on our hands, after all, and they're someone angered by the killings." She pauses. "Why didn't you tell the authorities? If you'd told them, they could have stopped the murders before they grew out of hand!"

The pastor shakes his head. "Many of our members thought it best to keep the matter a secret. I suppose in retrospect; they may have had *other* reasons. I didn't give it much thought at the time."

Thoroughly angered, Cassiel flips her hair back with a quick motion of her head. "I guess you're just a humble minister. It's not your fault if things get taken too far, isn't that right?"

The pastor can't think of a way to respond. "I, err, well... I thought like that, yes."

He doesn't even try to retort. Staring at the sullen man before me, I'm reminded of people who did the same thing in the time before I entered the Cryopod. *Careless fomentation of anger leads to tragedy.* It's funny how things change, yet always stay the same.

"Come on, Cass. There's a killer on the loose. Two, even, counting the vigilante. We won't solve these murders until we follow the trail back to the one who started it."

She nods, depression in her eyes. "Thank you for the help, Father Matlock. Please keep your preaching in check from now on."

"I will." The man says, more reserved than when we first met him. As Cassiel and I turn and walk away, I steal a glance back. He's staring at the broom; his shoulders slumped in defeat. He isn't as stupid as I thought; he knows he caused the deaths of those demons.

The church door slams behind us, and Cassiel stares up toward the midday sun. "Who could be the killer, Jason? We have so many demons to sort through that it'll take us weeks to narrow down the list of suspects."

"Someone who hates humans, obviously." A face appears in my mind, but I shake the feeling *Beelzebub can't be the killer. I ordered him never to hurt humans, and he can't disobey my orders.* "Let's start with the demons freed from the camps recently. Perhaps one of them has a bone to pick with the 'fleshbags.'"

Cassiel nods. "Samantha's going to be back soon. Let's solve this before she returns. I don't want her thinking less of the demons in the city just because there's one killer on the loose."

Her words make me pause as we step off the grass before the church. "You know, it hasn't been confirmed only *one* demon was responsible. There could be several involved. Like a conspiracy or something."

A snorting sound makes me glance at Cassiel as she chuckles. "Oh goodness, conspiracies! Those are always so silly!"

"Yeah, you got that right."

* * *

"PILOT BENJAMIN BROWN, YOUR VITAL SIGNS CONTINUE TO STEADILY DECREASE. AT THIS RATE, YOUR INTERNAL ORGANS WILL FAIL IN T-MINUS TWO DAYS, SIX HOURS-"

"Stuff it, Centurion." I cough the words out and stumble through the dark corridor, my suit lighting up the path just enough to see maybe fifty feet in front of me. "Tin can, you sure this is the right way?"

The robot beside me walks along calmly evaluating every step, his natural gait filling me with jealousy thanks to the pain he doesn't have to endure. "Response: Supreme Commander Jason Hiro, as well as the Angel designated Cassiel, and the Demon designated Samantha entered the Labyrinth, but I hold no maps of the area. Extrapolation: Based on the heavy footprints visible on the ground, the Sentinel designated Ionis headed in this direction. It is likely his superior sensors would lead him to where they-"

"I get the point. God, you hunks of junk talk so- hnggh," I pause and take a short breath as more stabbing pain erupts in my kidneys. "-talk so damn much. Just keep the responses to ten words or less."

What am I even doing? It's pointless. Everything went to shit, and it's all because of that fucking Jason guy. He lead them right to us. I'm not going to find him, and I'll die all alone, in the darkness of this fucking Labyrinth, and all I'll have beside me for company are these two stupid annoying squawk-boxes.

Maybe I deserve to die. After all, I'm not even the real Benjamin Brown. I'm a copy- a fake. Most of the commanding officers were clones. What was I even fighting for?

It doesn't matter. Nothing does. We're born, we live, and we die. I should have jumped in a shuttle and flown to a rimworld, lived my life in peace. It would have mattered as much to the fucking galaxy as dying to Kolpox.

At the least, if I can find Jason, I can warn him. I can tell him that it's all his fault. They've won the war, we've lost. And soon, so will the Volgrim.

"PILOT BENJAMIN BROWN, YOUR INTERNAL ORGANS WILL FAIL IN T-MINUS TWO DAYS, SIX HOURS, SEVEN MINUTES-"

"If you were a human, I'd punch you right in the face."

With my luck, the Kolpox won't kill me. It... it'll probably *turn* me.

I can't let the last Hypersuit fall into Volgrim, Demon, or Kolvaxian hands. Only humans deserve the power.

I have to hold on... just a little longer.

Part 457c: Explosion

The sound of snoring, a slow rise into a loud crescendo, makes me furrow my brow before fluttering my eyes open. It takes a moment, but I quickly realize it isn't *me* snoring, but Cassiel. I stare at the back of her head and watch her chest rise and fall, wondering to myself when she started doing that. Has she always snored?

Her snoring increases in volume a bit as her throat roughens the noise, and soon it's obnoxiously loud, to the point where I'm completely awake. I guess the idea that only ugly and old men snore is a myth, huh?

Silently, I pull my arms away from her and slide to the edge of the bed, flipping my feet over to stare at the door. I'm not going to sleep anymore, tonight, that's for sure.

Glancing to my left, I spot Ionis standing against the wall, his retinal sensor staring directly at me. I've grown used to it over the last few weeks, but sometimes I get a chill down my back when I wake up and realize he's been watching Cassiel and I sleep. A second later I glance down and spot Howard lying on Ionis's foot; his eyes closed as he dreams about whatever it is that ducks do. Why isn't he in the bed I made for him? It's cushier than mine! Whatever. Silly duck.

As I sit on the bed, contemplating the universe and my lack of nightmares lately, a soft knock at the door nearly makes me jump out of my skin. I was *not* prepared for that!

I whisper under my breath " **Wear,** " and my clothes appear in an instant, as I gently get off the bed and sneak to the door.

When I open it, I stare in stunned silence for a moment or two. "Samantha? You're back?"

"Mhm!" Samantha glances past me and spots Cassiel sleeping, so she keeps her voice low.

I step out of our room and quietly close the door behind me, even as Cassiel's snoring starts to sound like an idling chainsaw. *Jesus Christ, Cass.*

"How did it go? You're back several days early."

She leaps into my arms and squeaks a little bit. "It went alright, but I was *so* bored! This magic orc named Grok teleported me there and saved me a few days of trekking, so that was cool." She kisses me and grins, but for a moment I see a glint of hesitation in her eyes.

"Everything went well, then? You weren't punished?"

Her smile lessens, and she pulls away to fidget with her *clothing strips*. "K-kinda? I don't know."

"What do you mean you don't know?" Her expression is starting to worry me. "If you don't want to tell me, that's fine. It's not my business."

"No, no, it's not that," Samantha says, scuffing her foot on the ground. "I just... *can't remember*. I went to the council; they stripped me of my title of Second Emperor, and then they banished me from the Labyrinth, but-"

"What?!" I can't help myself, and the word spits out of my mouth, interrupting her mid-sentence. "They banished you?! That's-" I pause, realizing my voice is too loud, so I force myself to calm down. "-That's awful. How is that an 'alright' outcome, Sam? You were banished!"

She bites her lip and averts her eyes. "Well, that's the thing. See, I'm the Second Emperor because I'm leagues more powerful than any other demon or most combinations of demons. They don't have any way to enforce a banishment without the First Emperor enforcing it." Her expression darkens. "And so, they sent me to the First Emperor for final judgment."

She doesn't elaborate, so after a few moments, I prod her. "And...?"

"I don't know." She shrugs. "Since I wasn't escorted out of the Labyrinth, he must have let me go. No punishment."

"Must have? What, you don't remember?" Even as I ask the question, I recall her telling me something not too long ago... "Wait, don't tell me- he erased your memory after you revisited him?"

Samantha chews on her thumb silently for a moment. "Yeah." Her nerves get the better of her, as any attempt at a happy demeanor vanishes. She crosses her arms and sulks. "I don't know what we talked about, said, or did. I just know that the punishment wasn't enforced. It's... it's sorta irritating. I stopped visiting him a few million years ago because I got tired of meetings I would forget immediately afterward. What's the big idea?"

"Well, at least you got off easy, I guess," I say, shrugging along. "Though you look bothered about more than just the meeting. Is there something else?"

Her eyes lose focus, as she looks past my face at something unseen. "Well... I had this- this theory... about the First Emperor... it's probably wrong. Ah, it's nothing, I'm sure." She shakes her head and looks away, unable to meet my eyes, but something about the look makes me instantly suspicious.

Before I can ask anything, the door to our room opens, and Cassiel stumbles out, her eyes only half-open. "Jaaason! I'm cold! Why'd you get out of bed if you were just going to stand out here and-" She freezes for a moment before her eyes bolt open. "Ohmygosh, Sammy! You're back already?!"

Shoving past me, Cassiel leaps forward and hugs Samantha tightly. "We were so worried about you! Jason thought they were going to cut you up into little pieces and feed you to the Grez, but I told him 'no sir!' and you're way too tough for something like that to happen!"

Quietly, I mutter under my breath, "...but I never said anything like that..."

Neither of them hears me. Samantha hugs Cassiel back just as fiercely, though Cassiel whimpers in pain. "Too strong! Help! Lemme go!"

"Oh, oops. Sorry. Sometimes I forget my strength." Samantha blushes and releases Cass, and soon the three of us look from one to the other.

Cass breaks the sudden silence. "So how did it go? Did you show the council who's boss?"

"Um." Samantha shoots a glance at me before smiling weakly. "Not exactly. I think I was banished. They sent me to see the First Emperor, but he erased my memory. I don't know what happened after that."

Cassiel's angelic smile evaporates instantly. The sudden change in her expression almost makes me take a step back in surprise. "Is it because of what you told me? About his identity?"

"Maybe." Samantha doesn't look at me, but I suddenly realize this must have been something they discussed in private while I was chasing after that mystery woman.

Cassiel slowly licks her lips and glances away before turning to look at me. "Jason. I think you should restore Samantha's memories. Use your Wordsmithing."

"What?" Samantha responds before I can. "Hold on a sec, why do you say that?"

"I've been thinking about what you told me. The First Emperor might be who you think he is. If that's the case, erasing your memory might be for a sinister purpose. Restoring the past is the only way to be sure."

I have no idea what they're talking about. The fact neither one of them included me in this theory probably means they're trying to keep something from me. Ordinarily, I'd be annoyed, but neither Samantha nor Cassiel have ever lied as far as I know. They must have a reason.

Despite Cassiel's pushiness, Samantha is hesitant. "I don't know, Cass. Maybe I should think about it. I don't wanna rush anything."

The angel doesn't let up. "No, that look on your face says otherwise. Whatever happened while you saw the First Emperor, it was something that needs to be addressed. At the least, Jason can return your memories, you can confirm if they should stay repressed, and he can hide them again. Don't you think that's for the best?"

I've never seen Samantha this nervous. Any pretenses of being flirty, happy, or any hints of positive emotions are gone. She's even starting to shake, as the thought of her memories being returned fills her with dread. "W-we shouldn't, Cass. Let's just put it off for a while and drop it, okay?"

Cass stays silent for a few long moments. "He's using you, Sam. If you're right about the First Emperor's identity, I'm almost a hundred percent certain you wouldn't be let off the hook for a banishment without good reason. Think about it."

Silently, I lean back against the wall and watch the two of them argue for a couple more minutes. Every time Cassiel pushes more, Samantha clams up. Their argument makes my head spin, and they continue bantering until Samantha finally explodes.

"Jeez, fine, Cass! I'll just- Jason can restore my memory! Would you let up already?! It's not even a big deal!"

Cassiel sighs. "Okay, okay. I'm sorry. I'm not pushy just because, Sam. I have a reason. Let's just do this and get it over with."

"I can't wait." Samantha stares at Cass in annoyance for a few moments, but the anger deflates, like air released from a balloon. "Do it, Jason."

I feel nervous suddenly. "Oh, you want your memory restored? Err, I've never actually done it before..."

"Just give it a try, *honey*." Cassiel leans over and loops her arm through mine, sinking a lot of sweetness into that last word. "I'm sure you'll figure out what to do."

"Uh, okay then. H-here goes..."

I stare at Samantha for a few moments as I try to picture in my mind the word used to bring her memories back, as well as how I want it to work. *Let her remember the First Emperor, and her interactions with him. That should do it.* " **Restore!** "

The words leave my mouth, and Samantha's face stays neutral. For a few moments, she stares at me blankly. "Did it work? I don't feel-"

She stops mid-sentence, and her eyes lose focus.

A flash of pain appears on her face. Her lips quiver, and her jaw clenches.

Moments later, she screams. "AHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHH!!!" A horrible, gut-wrenching wail, as Samantha doubles over on the floor and clenches her stomach. Cassiel and I both leap back in fright. The wretched, high-pitched scream is like that of a banshee, sending daggers of ice into every pore on our bodies. For ten straight seconds, the scream continues, unabated, without her pausing to draw a breath.

And just as suddenly, it stops. Sam's entire body shakes for several seconds, as if she were spasming from a bone-chill, before she goes completely still, and stays huddled on the floor.

"S-Sammy? Sam?" Cassiel trembles as we both stare down at her. "Are you... okay?"

It takes a few seconds, but I realize Samantha is whispering under her breath. The volume increases until I can make out what she's saying.

"...no...no...no...no...no..."

Over and over, she repeats the word. She stops after a minute, but Cassiel and I are too afraid to say anything.

Finally, Samantha slowly raises her head up to look at us. Blood trickles down from her eyes and nose, and her lip is savagely chewed, and if she's damn-near bitten the goddamn thing off.

"I'm scum."

Finally, she speaks two words, after long, painful moments of silence. The bloody tears swap with watery tears, as Samantha leaps to her feet, and rushes past me, hurling me halfway down the hallway. I hit the ground hard enough to hear a rib crack, and I wince in pain. A moment later, the door to our room slams shut, and Cassiel and I stare at each other in stunned silence. I can barely even feel the pain from my fractured rib, thanks to the adrenaline pumping through my veins.

"What... what the hell... just happened?" I can scarcely form the words.

More screaming erupts from the room, and the sound of furniture smashing against the walls makes me flinch. *Samantha's going berserk.*

"St-stay here, Jason. I'm going to try and calm her down." Cassiel swallows hard but pauses as she turns to the door. "I didn't expect a reaction like this. This is worse than anything I could have imagined."

After gathering her wits, Cassiel quickly opens the door, steps into the room, and slams it shut behind her.

My breathing halts as I hear the muffled voices inside. I can't make out a single word, and I'm not sure I want to. The smashing of furniture stops, and all I can hear is the awful wailing of a woman crying her heart out.

The First Emperor, huh? " **Heal.** "

My rib repairs itself, and I pull myself up. *I'm going to kill that son of a bitch.*

Part 458c: Born In Fire

"Scoot over! Come on, move your ass!" Tvoorik gives me a rough shove despite my protests, squeezing me up against a rather large and well-endowed Orc. The bench is jam-packed full of demons, and the entire theater must have around fifty thousand of us. Heck, even the domed ceiling above has various demons crawling around on it, scrambling to find suitable hanging spots from which to view the spectacle.

Tvoorik smiles and nods his big, stupid head excitedly. "Oh boy, this is gonna be exciting! An announcement from the Demon Council! I bet it's regarding the Second Emperor! She's outta here!"

I try to contain my excitement and succeed thanks to the fact I don't give a crap. "Yeah, wow, I can't wait. Why do you care, anyway? I thought you hated the demon leadership?"

"Oh, I do!" Tvoorik waves his hand at me dismissively. "I mean, pff, just think about it, old buddy old pal! If she's out, maybe that's a sign they'll start changing things up a bit! Diablo's out of commission for a while, so maybe Mephisto's gonna do a better job."

I squint to look fifty rows ahead at the stage. It's so far in the distance I can barely even make it out, especially with all the orcs blocking the view. Who thought seating the tallest bodies in the front rows was a good idea? Shadow-walkers are too short to see past them! At least we're seated close to the front, since the room stretches back several hundred layers.

"Yeah, maybe Mephisto will do something. I'm jumping for joy."

Inwardly, I sigh. Tvoorik was vindicated on at least one count thanks to this last incursion against the humans. We don't stand a chance beating the humans, even with the power of the First Emperor. Just when we thought we had them on the ropes, the Hero returned, and with the help of the Second Emperor, he wiped out our Third Emperor and took us down. With results like that, there isn't a chance we can win now.

I pause, thinking for a moment on something I learned recently. "Say, Tvoorik."

"Yeah? What?" He looks at me, suspicion in his eyes. I'm not one to ask questions, so it's a natural reaction.

"You remember how we were talking about that angel amidst the humans, recently?"

"Uh huh." He gives me a dumb look, but I ignore it.

"Rumor has it that the humans are calling her the Divine Mother. They say she's an archangel."

"Of *course* they do." Tvoorik looks away almost immediately and rolls his eyes. "It's like I said; the angels work for the demons. It's obvious to anyone with a *brain*. She's a convenient scapegoat for that awful failure of a battle against the humans a few weeks ago. There's no way she's an archangel."

Before I can respond, a Felaris girl in front of us half turns around, and her catlike ears twitch. "Divine Mother? Is that what I heard you say?"

I crinkle my nose at her. The Felaris are much too human-like for my taste, and very ugly by demon standards. "Yeah. Mind your business."

"Aww, that's rude." Her ears cock downward, an obvious attempt to elicit sympathy. "One of my fifteen sisters lives amidst the humans, and she told me the Divine Mother is real. She's an angel of unthinkable beauty, and wise beyond her years."

Tvoorik scoffs. "Cheh, your sister's a human-lover. Anything she says is suspect. They probably brainwashed her with their mind-control beams. I'd cut off contact with her if I were you."

The orc beside me rubs his fat, disgusting belly and picks his nose. "Hu hu hu, me like pretty girl. Wonder if Difine Mudder like big strong orc?"

As he raises his arm to examine the booger, the stench from his pit wafts over me. "I doubt that very much."

Tvoorik glares at me, but the expression is directed more at the Felaris. I can almost hear his thoughts. *Maybe going to this event was the wrong idea after all.*

We don't have time to reconsider. The room suddenly goes quiet, as a wave of silence washes over from the front rows all the way to the back. A few orcs ahead of us continue laughing and jeering, but they're always loud and obnoxious, so I ignore them.

An old demon slowly walks onto the stage and makes a motion with his hands, probably to amplify his voice with magic. I squint, but can't make out his face. "Tvoorik, who is that?"

He shrugs. "Dunno. Some geezer."

The Felaris girl spins her head back to hiss at us. "That's Barbatos, the eldest demon! Show respect!"

"As if I care," Tvoorik says, echoing my thoughts.

The old bat mutters something unintelligible for a moment before clearing his throat. "Ah, thank you for coming today, esteemed demon and monster-kin. I am Barbatos, the Father of Demons. This announcement is regarding several minor and major things that will be changing,

starting immediately. It will be your duty to return to each of your districts and inform the relevant leaders and broodmothers about..."

He drawls on for a while, and I begin to feel my attention drift. *Healing centers are overcrowded; mutations are lagging behind, blah blah blah...*

"With regards to the Second Emperor... most of you may have heard about her recent expulsion from the Demon Emperors..." Barbatos catches my attention with this statement. He sighs before continuing. "Belial has been expunged from the Demon Emperors, but the First Emperor has chosen to show mercy and will not banish her from the Labyrinth. However, given Belial is a known human sympathizer, she is to be avoided at all costs. She battled and defeated the Third Emperor, Diablo, in combat to defend the humans, an action irredeemable in the eyes of the Council. As a result, Diablo has been unable to lead us due to his injuries..."

"Tch. Good riddance," Tvoorik mutters under his breath.

"Hey, that's not fair. Diablo is a friend of ours."

Tvoorik nods slowly. "Yeah, I like him as a demon, but Bael would be much better as a leader."

"Bael is a lunkhead. I can't believe you prefer him to Diablo." I pause, realizing what I just said. "Never mind. You probably feel a kinship with his stupidity."

"Oh, shut up."

Barbatos holds up a piece of parchment and squints to read it. "Mmm. Mmm, yes, I see. And now I bring you the final bit of news. Due to a series of recent circumstances, it is with great regret that I inform you Diablo will no longer, as of this day, represent Demonkind as our Third Emperor. Indeed, with the purge of Belial, he would be promoted to the position of Second, while Bael would be promoted to Third, but times have changed. A promising candidate has appeared and demonstrated without a doubt that he has the qualifications to lead demonkind as our new Second Emperor!"

I stare at the stage, stupefied. It takes a moment for the old bat's words to register. "A different demon will be the Second Emperor? Who? Mephisto?"

Tvoorik shakes his head. "I doubt that... he's acting like this new candidate is an unknown. Mephisto would be expected for the role."

Indeed, Barbatos beckons to the side of the stage, and from the shadows, out steps a demon I haven't seen before. A black suit, with a black tie, and a black undershirt combine with his black hair and red skin to create a stunning contrast. He carries himself with poise, and strides

forward, smiling as he bows to the audience. Barbatos makes a motion, and the newcomer's voice is amplified for all to hear.

"Greetings, comrades. Many of you may know of me, but will not know my story. I am Beelzebub, your new Second Emperor. You may call me by my new title, the Emperor of Flames."

Everyone, myself included, stare at him in silence, as he continues. Even the orcs don't make a sound, which is out of the ordinary for them. "Due to the failings of the previous leadership, I have sought to remedy the problems plaguing demon society." His smile twists, and a snarl forms on his face. "Weakness. This infectious disease plagues us. Losing to humans in combat is inexcusable. If we couldn't beat them with our eons of fighting experience, simply overrunning them with millions and billions of our kind would have sufficed. Instead, we allowed them to claim a sizeable victory, and have sustained a blow to our morale while boosting theirs. Inexcusable!"

A tap on my arm turns my attention to Tvoorik. He raises a knowing eyebrow. "Do you know who this is, Ylvusk?"

I shake my head, and he quickly explains. "He's the 'Puppet' demon. The Hero supposedly beat him in combat and enslaved his mind. Now he comes out as our new Second Emperor? Fishy..."

Memories come back to me. A few years ago, I remember hearing tales of such a demon, but... "That can't be him. It makes no sense."

Tvoorik doesn't respond. Beelzebub continues speaking, his voice rising as he gets more and more into his speech. "My power comes from the Third Emperor, Diablo. Two nights ago, I defeated Diablo and Bael in combat and took Diablo's energy for myself. If you lend me your attention, I will explain just how my glorious rise began."

I groan inwardly. "This is going to be a long one."

* * *

"Out of my way! I have business with those two inside."

Before me stood a hundred demons, armed to the teeth. Diablo and Bael's guardsmen, there to protect them in case of people like myself. Each one raised their weapons to me; their teeth gritted in anger.

"We shan't let you pass, knave! Ye are not worthy of seeing the Third Emperor and First Duke without an invitation!"

One of the guards started to thrust his spear at me, but he was met with a swift, fiery demise. The flames boiled from within my body and lashed out, like a bird of prey snatching a field mouse. As he fell, the other guards leaped back in panic, unable to believe my incredible power.

"F-fine, you can go in! But when you do, you'll be sorry! The Third Emperor will make you pay!"

Naturally, that guard tasted the same flames as the one before him. The rest were far too frightened to raise a weapon to me, so they thrust their swords and spears to the ground and cowered, begging for their lives.

Shoving the bodies out of my way with a single, swift kick, I charged into the blood-pits and stood before the failed demon leaders.

"Diablo, Third Emperor of Hell! Bael, First Duke of Hell! I challenge you both to a duel! I will take your energy for myself!"

Immediately, Diablo swiveled to face me, fear in his eyes. He knew at once that his reckoning had come. No longer could he sit idly by as he fooled around, making life miserable for those below him. His failures would be atoned for in blood.

"I-I'm not scared of you! B-but, before you can beat me in combat, you must first face my right-hand demon. Yes, that's right! I'll not have it any other way!"

The mark of an insect! He forced his underling to fight and weaken me first, but knew it couldn't save him. Bael reached for his tiny flail and laughed, thinking he stood a chance against my awesome power.

"If you think you can beat the First Duke, you're wrong. Your time is up, Beelze-"

Before he could even finish, I had already conjured a small, intensely hot ball of fire within my palm. Instantly, I lobbed it at him, but the dullard was too slow to react in time. It smote his body and sent him smashing backward, landing against the wall of the hut. His insignificant demonhood flopped to the side as he passed out from the pain. Truly, a pathetic display, for a worthless underling.

"Diablo, you can escape no longer. Your days of hiding and leaving the fighting to others are over. Now you must face me, and be wrapped in the embrace of my fire to atone for your failures as our leader."

Diablo leaped out of the blood pits. His body was already fully healed! Everything he told us about his grievous wounds was a lie! He soaked in warm, iron-rich human blood while the

demons below him wept and perished at the hands of the filthy fleshbags. I grew enraged, knowing this traitor thought himself fit to lead.

The former Third Emperor, trembled as he faced me. "Won't you take pity, on a poor, injured demon? This fight isn't fair! I can scarcely move!"

"Lies!" I pointed my finger straight at his chest. "You're the picture of health! Stop sniveling, and fight me for the right to rule! If you won't, I'll take your power by force!"

Finally, the former Third Emperor realized he could hide no longer. In a display of cowardice, he charged at me before I was ready! He delivered many savage blows to my head and body, but I managed to escape his weak grip and quickly summoned a wall of flame to engulf him. His screams were sweet as nectar, and they filled me with joy, knowing he could finally feel the pain that so many other demons had experienced at the hands of the humans!

He writhed in pain on the ground, before reaching out and slapping my foot.

"I concede! Please, have mercy! You are far more worthy than I to lead our people! I will give you my energy, just don't kill me! I beg you!"

Naturally, he made the right choice in the end. While his energy flowed to me, I spat on him and cursed his weakness, before stepping out of the hut. All the demons present took several steps back as they gazed in awe of my strength. To demonstrate my mercy, I used my new energy to repair the vital organs of those I had harmed. They might never speak properly again, but at least they would live to fight in service of their glorious new leader.

* * *

Beelzebub's grin widens, nearly to maniacal levels. As he continues, I nudge Tvoorik. "This story sounds a little twisted, don't you think?"

I pause, noticing Tvoorik staring in awe at Beelzebub. "Incredible! An outsider wrested control from the previous leaders! He could take us to new heights!" His glee increases even further, "And Diablo was such a coward, too! I can't believe that guy!"

"Huh?" My eyes blink twice, just to make sure I'm hearing him right. "Listen to what he said, Tvoorik. That was a whole lot of hot air and not much substance. I bet he made half of it up."

"Pfft, nonsense." Tvoorik looks at me like *I'm* the idiot here. "A bit of embellishing for the audience. Everyone exaggerates a little. How else do you think it could have gone down? I wanna give him a chance!"

Beelzebub's words drift over from the stage, catching my attention. "-are worthless fleshbags, as you all know. During my time among the humans, I learned much about how they behave, and what their weaknesses are. My goal as the new Second Emperor is to completely,

utterly, and totally annihilate humanity! After they're defeated, we will take on the Volgrim. It will not be an easy road. Many have died as a result of these humans, but that is precisely why I will be the perfect new leader! We need not just new blood up here, but new ideas! I bring with me a re-imagination of war itself, and a new focus on how to destroy the humans."

"Humans are inventive. They create their fancy gadgets and toys because they are fragile, and those weapons are the only way they can hope to defeat demons in combat. We will no longer engage in all-out war against them, but guerrilla combat. Those who fancy the shadows, the cloak and dagger, they will be our deadliest agents in this new era. We will target not the human body, but the human psyche. We must sow discord among our enemies, make them doubt who the real monsters are. A human's deadliest weapon is neither the gun, nor the bomb, but the *ideas* which they spread. Their ideas corrode the soul, and weaken the mind."

The orc beside me blinks sleepily. "Suit-guy speak big words. Glonk not understand."

I nudge him with my arm. "You and me both. He sounds like a clown. I can't believe we traded Diablo for *this*." Even as I say the words, I notice Tvoorik's stupid, over-eager expression. The dumbass is lapping up every word.

"So join me, brothers and sisters! We will work together and recreate demon society! The River Styx will overflow with the souls of humans, and my new laws will ensure that those who kill the most are rewarded for their hard work. No more cowering while we wait for the humans to expand to a new district! No more whining because you haven't mutated in millennia! Pledge your loyalty to your new Second Emperor, and the weakness of the past will soon become a distant memory!"

The entire throng of demons explodes into cheers all at once, sans an individual here and there. While Tvoorik stands up and claps like a madman, as do many others, all I can do is bow my head and sigh.

"So this is how stability dies; with thunderous applause."

Part 459c: Deception, Disgrace

"P-please calm down! Sam!" I flinch as a sturdy oaken chair smashes against the wall beside me, and Samantha screams again, pounding the chessboard Jason was playing with last night into a thousand pieces, much of them the size of dust fragments.

"I lied! I'm worthless! I'm pathetic!" Samantha kicks a metal pail hard enough that it blasts across the room and smashes against Ionis, bouncing off his metal frame and ricocheting off the walls until it pounds into her chest and knocks her over. Her sudden surprise might almost be comical if she weren't in such incredible emotional pain. "Aauuuoo!"

She crumples in a heap behind the bed in a corner and starts sobbing uncontrollably. Before I hesitantly walk over to her, I steal a glance at the Sentinel. If he's angry about the pail, he doesn't show it. The robot continues to stare straight ahead unamusedly as if none of this matters to him in the slightest. Howard hides behind Ionis's legs but doesn't appear to be mortally terrified. As long as Ionis protects him, I don't have to worry.

I tiptoe over to Sammy and chew my lip. She's curled up in the fetal position on the floor, her arms wrapped around her legs as the tears come pouring down. Whatever Jason made her remember, it's more than she can handle.

"Sam. I'm here." I turn my wings into warm, comfortable pillows as I kneel down and wrap my arms around her. My wings act as a barrier to the outside world, reflecting the negative energy permeating our room away from her.

After a minute of uncontrollable hysterics, she manages to calm down somewhat, aided in part by the pure energy I subtly send to her. "Oh god, Cass... I can't believe myself! How could I do it?!"

"I don't know what you mean, Sammy. You have to take a deep breath, calm your heart, and realize that I'm here for you. Okay? Only after you do that can you tell me what's wrong."

Only a few weeks ago, I was the one crying in Sammy's arms, after I remembered what Marie did to me. If I can't be a tree to help weather the storm, I'm not a real friend. I'm just surprised I can be so calm in the face of such strong, repressed emotions.

The crying winds down, and soon she rests her head on my chest, staring stonily at the wall. "I was right. The First Emperor is Satan. He's been erasing my memories."

Ooh, that was blunter than I expected. "Yes, you told me as much. Can you tell me what happened? I won't judge you for anything, no matter what."

Samantha doesn't respond for over a minute, before whispering, "Really? Not at all? But... I'm awful..."

"I don't think so, and neither does Jason. Open up your heart, and I'll listen."

She squeezes her legs even tighter. "I... after I went to the council, I was sent to see the First- I mean, to see Satan. Nobody knows who he is. He wipes everyone's memory."

"Mhm." I keep my reply neutral.

"W-well, when I showed up to see him..."

* * *

After how weak and ineffective I made the council look, I was feeling pretty good about myself. I arrived at the secret door to the First Emperor's chamber. When I stepped inside, it was a long walk down a hallway, where I felt his dark miasma radiating down the corridor. His power was overwhelming, like trying to swim up against a waterfall. In a way, it sickened me, somehow, as if I could no longer stand the feeling of negative energy.

I washed the lumps in my throat down and finally arrived in his throne room. I wasn't sure exactly what to expect, but I knew what his name was, or at least, the one he'd chosen to tell everyone.

Striking a cocky pose, I stared up at the giant behemoth sitting upon his throne. "Yo. What's up, 'Asmodeus'?"

I've always been a carefree soul. While I couldn't remember any of our previous meetings, I was confident this is how I'd greet anyone claiming to be the First Emperor, and the fact I hadn't been executed or punished during any of my previous meetings seemed proof to me that it wasn't the wrong way to greet him.

Ah, Second Emperor, Belial. It has been a long time. Where have you been, my love? "

His voice was filled with honey and sugar, but at the same time, there was a moment where I sensed a hint of rage. It had been thousands of years since I last saw him since I'd long since tired of never remembering what we talked about or did. Knowing what I know now, perhaps he was just angry I hadn't been popping in every so often.

"I'm not your 'love', unless, of course, your name isn't Asmodeus. That's a silly thought, isn't it?" A duality was in my words. On the one hand, I was implying without directly stating that he couldn't be Asmodeus at all, but on the other hand, I wasn't saying outright *who* my lover was. Because the thing is... I'd been having doubts.

The arch-demon's voice softened. Before my eyes, his form began to shrink from a towering colossus to something only a little taller than myself. It was only once his face changed from a black, shapeless mess, to one I'd seen before, that I felt my heart quiver.

"Well, then, Lilia... I suppose if my name isn't 'Asmodeus,' then that little statement falls to pieces?"

I didn't have a chance to reply. A moment later, a gentle sensation, like wind formed in the shape of a hand, swept me off my feet and over to him, pressing my body against his. I barely had a second to react before he plunged his lips onto mine, and kissed me with a fiery passion I hadn't experienced in ages...

"W-wait!" I pulled my mouth from his and pushed away, feeling annoyed all of a sudden. The whole situation felt rushed. "I-I barely even- I mean, we haven't seen each other in-"

His eyes hardened, ever so slightly. "Oh, come now. You've dropped by many a time, sweet Lilia. Not *recently*, I'll admit, but plenty of times before. I've grown antsy, even on occasion filling the void you've left me in with other trifles, but no woman matches you. I'm just glad you've gathered your senses and made a return."

"I don't remember the past, Satan." I tried not to glare at him, but a small amount of anger boiled up inside of me. "I'm glad *one of us* remembers the good old days."

As if realizing his error, Satan took a step back and tapped his hips. "Yes, hmm, I see your point. Of course, I've explained to you on countless occasions why I must keep my identity a secret, but I suppose I'll have to explain again."

And so he did. He spent fifteen minutes talking while I listened silently. I didn't understand most of it. Something about time travel, paradoxes, the future being linear, other universes... if I'm being honest, it wasn't the sort of thing a *demon* would understand. These concepts were very... human.

"Oh. Okay." I nodded slowly, but I didn't understand what he meant.

Satan seemed to realize this. "Yes, I suppose you wouldn't understand, but that is fine, my dear. After all, it is a man's place to think, and a woman's to listen. Now, where have you been for all of this time? My bed has grown quite cold."

His condescending words didn't hit me as they should have. Somehow, my mind closed them out, and I thought to myself something like, *oh, that's just the way he is*. Looking back on it now, maybe I should have noticed the warning signs.

My arms crossed over my chest, and I suddenly felt a tiny amount of shame, being in his presence. "I've just- well, I've been out, doing things. The war with the humans is heating up.

I've been-"

"The war with the humans? Oh right, that nonsense Diablo was telling me about. I nearly fell asleep listening to him. As if I cared about *humans*." Satan tossed his hand up in the air flippantly. "If Diablo can't handle the humans and he wastes my power, I'll be dreadfully annoyed. I expect you'll help out if it comes to that."

Even as he said all this, Satan was slowly edging closer to me. A hungry lust was in his eyes, as though he was just trying to skip to the good parts, ignoring my feelings along the way. He didn't seem to care about the fact that I hadn't seen him in millions of years, from my point of view, nor did he care about taking the time to rekindle a romance or anything else. He only had *one thing* on his mind.

And frankly, I'd had enough. "I'm seeing another man right now, Satan. A human."

He didn't even pause. "Wonderful. I'm sure once he's drained, you'll be hungry for more. It's like eating the crumbs that have fallen off the table, while the main course lingers above. Let's cut the chit-chat, Lilia. I've missed you so much, you know. I respected your desire for a little alone time, but now that you're here..."

I jerked back in fright as he suddenly appeared inches in front of me, and his hand reached down behind me to grab hold of my flesh. *Teleportation?* I hadn't even seen him make a sign, and it scared me, seeing him act so aggressive.

"I don't want this!" Out of instinct, I hit him with all my power and sent him hurtling backward. He smashed into his throne with a sickening *crunch* and destroyed a good chunk of the lower-section. Immediately, worry and fear overtook me. "Oh devils, Satan?! Are you okay?!"

"Ahhh..." His moan of pain almost had a hint of pleasure in it. "It's been so long since we were together, Lilia..." He pulled himself out of the debris and rubbed his back. "...I had forgotten that side of you. I must admit, I do like it more when you playfully resist."

Seeing he was okay and not seriously injured, my worry vanished. "I'm not playing around! I didn't come here for this! I have another man now, Satan! I can't just jump in bed with you, not without talking to him first."

For a moment, the funniest look of confusion appeared on Satan's face, as if he couldn't fathom me saying 'no' to him. He thought I was joking around, up to that point, maybe leading him on, but a moment later, the comicality vanished.

"What do you mean by that?" His voice was calm, icy, but a threat lingered on the edge. "What human? Who is he?"

"That's... that's not important!" My arms crossed once more, but I could feel my body shaking. Suddenly I wished I were wearing a set of plate-armor. I felt exposed in front of him, as his eyes roved my body. "I'm my own person. Stop acting like you control me. I'm not chattel."

Despite the rising anger in his eyes, Satan managed to calm himself down as he walked a little closer and brushed crumbled rock and dust from his robes. "I see. This human... is his name Jason Hiro, by any chance?"

It took me a moment to form words. Satan had already demonstrated he had no idea what I was up to, nor what the state of the Labyrinth was, yet he knew Jason's name? Why?

"Yeah. So?"

His eyes raised and a knowing expression filled his face. "Ah, I see. The Wordsmith. I hadn't realized so much time had passed. I've grown too comfortable, it appears. Decades turned into centuries, which became millennia and eventually eons. The time has already arrived, and all I do is lounge around and wait for reports from my *others*." He paused after the last word as if it held some significance, but I couldn't divine what it was. "I've grown soft. All is well though since you did make that promise to me, all those ages ago."

"Promise? What promise?"

His tongue flicked out, and he licked his lips. "The betrayal, of course. The reason I erase your memory is so you can stay in character, but you and I both know... when the time comes, there is only one man to whom you can be loyal. This Jason fellow is a passing interest, a flippant moment in time. When the time is right, you will plunge the figurative dagger in his back, and then I will restore your memories."

Satan shrugged and heaved a great sigh. "Ah, well, I suppose that doesn't matter. You won't remember our time here afterward, anyway."

I had no idea what the promise was or what he was talking about, but something about his words chilled my heart. "Y-you're going to erase my memory again? Why? And what makes you think I'll betray Jason?"

"Huh? Now you're babbling." Satan's gaze hardened once more, but there was something sinister in his eyes this time. "This prattle is tiresome. You don't love him at all. You're just pretending, of course. He doesn't mean a thing to you. I am the only one you can truly love, Lilia, and you'd do well to remember that. He isn't kin, he's a human. Humans are filthy, worthless creatures, bound together in weakness. Demons are strong, and the rightful rulers of the universe."

My breath was coming in small, quick wheezes. Every word he was saying made my stomach churn. "I d-disagree! Humans are kind and caring. I've seen the love they can show for others of their species, and even other species as well! War doesn't have to be the only way we communicate!"

"Enough!" Satan's eyes flared up, and I could feel his energy shift slightly. "If you keep talking like that, I'm going to think you're serious!"

"I am serious! I'm not lying about-"

"Nonsense! That devil-damned human has brainwashed you!" Satan's teeth gnashed as he took several steps toward me. Suddenly, everything about him seemed more intimidating than usual. "Why don't you pause, and think for a moment! Use your head, Lilia! Come to me! Bow down and lick my feet!"

"What? No way! That's disgusting!"

My words stopped, and a pleasant feeling appeared in my mind. As if everything I had just said didn't matter, I took a hesitant step toward him. I couldn't see straight before. Jason didn't matter to me at all!

But no, he did! And yet, Satan suddenly seemed so alluring... I realized that there were things about him that Jason couldn't have, and that I was really in love with-

Damn it! It wasn't right! I knew it wasn't right, but I just wanted Satan so badly, at that very moment! It's as if my body was screaming out to him, and my mind couldn't fight back! It was... it was...

* * *

"It was a betrayal..." Fresh tears flow from her eyes, and Samantha wipes furiously at her face, before launching into a physical assault, punching her face violently. "Liar! Worthless! Scum!"

"Sammy, no! Stop!" I force energy into my arms and use all my strength to try and stop her from hitting herself, but it's not enough. A sickening popping sound makes me whimper as one of my shoulder-blades violently dislocates. "Aaaow!"

Finally, Samantha stops and pulls away. "Oh... oh no... Cass, I'm sorry- I didn't mean to do that..."

I grit my teeth and bear the pain. "You're just taking all the blame... please don't attack yourself anymore, Sammy. When you do that, it's others you hurt, not yourself."

She nods and quickly makes a hand motion to repair my shoulder. I nearly bite my tongue as the bones mend together, but a moment later, the pain is gone.

Both of us stare at each other before turning away and gazing out the window.

My heart finally slows down, now that her emotions have been poured out. Her tears dry up as she dabs at her face with the bed covers. "I can't believe I did it, Cass. I tried to be true to Jason, but in the end, I threw myself at Satan, and begged him to do anything he wanted to me. It's like I wasn't myself. There was another me, one that revealed itself when I least expected it." She lowers her eyes to stare at a broken chunk of the chessboard she destroyed. "Just like I'm going to hurt Jason."

I can't stand to see her hurting like this. "Sammy, I don't know what happened with Satan, but that wasn't you. Maybe you just missed him. From your point of view, you hadn't seen him in millions of years... you probably just realized at that moment how much you loved him, but that doesn't mean you'll betray Jason. After all, he loves you and me equally. There can be room in your heart for Jason and Satan as well."

Samantha shakes her head slowly. "Cass. I didn't tell you everything I remembered. Jason didn't just restore my memory of this last meeting with Satan. He restored *all* my memories of Satan. Thousands of them."

My breath catches. "What- what do you mean? What do you remember?"

"Everything." She crawls over to me and lays on my chest, pulling my wings over her. "Satan... he kept calling me to him, using me, then wiping my memory. All those times I went to visit him, he'd get his rocks off, then send me away. He never let me keep those memories. Those were *our* memories together. Why?"

Many possibilities occur to me, but I want to try the softer ones first. "Satan mentioned time travel and other things. Maybe you couldn't be allowed to remember him. Even Diablo wasn't allowed, right?"

"Uh huh... maybe. I dunno." Her voice is sullen. Depression seems to be setting in. "Every second that passes, I remember more and more things. The last thing he told me before he wiped my memory this last time was 'Sadly, you won't remember the good times we just had.' Maybe he wanted me to remember but couldn't. Maybe you're right, Cass."

My thoughts keep returning to the strange behavior Samantha described when she last saw him. "Sam, is it... is it possible that he was manipulating you with magic? Maybe that's why you acted so passionately. Perhaps he was manipulating-"

"No! No, he wouldn't do that!" Samantha flinches and closes her eyes. "He'd never hurt me like that. It must have been repressed lust... I'm just a whore like everyone says. A sex-starved succubus. Worthless!"

"C'mon, Sammy, not this line again." I bite my lip hard enough to taste blood. "It's not that far-fetched. Maybe he made a sign when you weren't looking, or maybe he-"

She pulls away from me again and glares at me. "Stop! Satan would never hurt me like that! Don't even say it! He loves me, Cass."

I don't know if he used magic or not, but she trusts him... would he? My mind parses the possibilities, but I don't want to think of what it could mean.

"Fine, I'm sorry. Look, don't beat yourself up over this, Sam. Whatever happened, it's in the past. Let's tell Jason what happened, and maybe he can help us figure it out. We're all in this together, right?"

"No, please, don't tell Jason. He'll think I'm... *contaminated*. He won't look at me the same."

"That's not true, damn you." I have to resist the urge to slap some sense into her, but it's very tempting. "Jason knew you loved the leader of the demons. If he finds out you made love to Satan, he won't be angry. He isn't like that."

"Jason will be disappointed. He'll feel betrayed." She rubs her arms slowly in a circular motion. "I don't know what to do, Cass. Never in my life has sex made me feel so filthy, but it does, now. I've done it millions of times, and it hasn't hurt me on the inside as it does at this moment. I want to die."

I want to die.

Her words echo in my memories. I once said the same thing. I screamed those words until my throat was ragged, but I was too weak to follow through. Samantha isn't weak; she's strong. If she wanted to, she could do it.

I can't let that happen.

"Sam, if you kill yourself, I'll kill myself. Jason will be all alone. Is that what you want?"

"Huh? No!" She jerks her head up and gawks at me, horror on her face. "Why would you say that?"

"You're my best friend. You're my lover too, Sam. I want to be with you as much as I do Jason. If you took your life, it would devastate both of us. We'd be ruined. Don't you remember what you told me on the ship?"

A guilty look crosses her face. "Yeah. I'm sorry... I was selfish."

"It's okay. Let's be selfish for a while together, okay? I won't tell Jason what happened; that's up to you. When you feel ready, pour your heart out to him. Only sincere regret will change anything, and you already have that down pat."

As she nods and thanks me, I lean in and kiss her passionately, hoping to myself I can replace the memories Satan gave her with more pleasant ones.

But deep inside myself, I feel an emotion I can't remember ever feeling before.

Rage.

I know he manipulated her, lied to her. She may not be willing to believe it, but I see Satan for what he is. He used her for his own pleasure, wiped her memories, and abused her innocent love for him with dramatic reunions, over and over again, for millions of years.

Even if she doesn't realize it, he broke her heart.

I'll break *him*.

Part 460c:

"Jason. Wake up... you dozed off."

The dreamless blackness lifts off in a flash, and I leap to my feet, nearly knocking Cassiel over as she pulls away. "Huh? Wha-? I wasn't sleeping! I was just resting my eyes!"

Normally she'd giggle and make a funny comment, but she just stares at me evenly. "I hope you're rested, in any case."

Our mood is tense, and I stuff my lopsided smile away. "How is Samantha? What happened? Was it the First Emperor? Did she-"

Cassiel raises a finger up and presses it against my lips, shushing me. "She's sleeping now. Many things happened while she was away, and let's just say that you restored a lot of memories she'd forgotten about. She's very confused right now."

Her words have a faint warning to them that makes the hair on the back of my neck stand up. "What do you mean? What did I make her remember?"

Cassiel shakes her head. "It's not for me to say. She'll tell you when she's feeling better." She locks her hands together and twines her fingers around before nibbling on her lower lip. "Look, it's late at night. I know she woke us up and all that, and you probably want to go back to bed..."

"My sleep can wait, Cass. Is there some way I can help Sam?"

"That isn't what I meant." Cassiel squirms a little bit as some thought bugs her. "Um. How about you sleep... somewhere else tonight? It'll just be Sam and me tonight, okay? Girl talk."

Something about what she's saying doesn't add up. It's like she's trying to say Samantha doesn't want to be around me at the moment, which seems possible given what she said before...

I'm scum.

What did she mean by that? Why would she say she was scum? Was it because of me? Did she remember something from her past involving me? Maybe it isn't even me at all, but something she did... maybe something involving her succubus blood.

I'm missing pieces to the puzzle. Damn it! Just tell me, and I can help!

I can't say that to Cass, though. She's giving me odd looks. I haven't said a word in several seconds...

"Alright. I'm in the doghouse; I get it. I'll find a nice couch to sleep on."

Cassiel's stone-cold expression softens, and guilt takes over. "What? No, no, that isn't what I meant, Jason! Don't be like *that*. She just needs some alone time with me, okay?"

Now *I'm* the one who feels bad. "I'm just playing around, Cass. I own this castle, so I'm sure there is a room unused somewhere nearby. If not I'll just magic up a new one. You two take care of yourselves." I pause for a moment, "But uh, I *do* want to know what happened. And soon. You know how rash I can sometimes be."

Slowly, Cassiel's lips curl up into a half smile. "I'm feeling pretty rash, myself. Jason, do you ever feel outraged? As in, somewhat inexplicably full of fury at nothing in particular?"

That isn't a question I ever expected Cassiel to ask me. "Not particularly. Usually, if I'm angry, it's at someone or something specific....Why?"

She licks her lips. "Just wondering."

"Are you angry at someone, Cass? Maybe me?"

She smiles, in spite of herself. "You're such a meanie sometimes. I'll see you in the morning, okay?"

"Yeah. Love you." I give her a quick kiss, but she pulls away and sneaks back down the hallway, closing the door to our room silently behind her.

I'm alone, now. Just me and my thoughts. I don't know what to think, though. Whatever happened to Samantha, it wasn't a joking matter. The First Emperor must be involved, including perhaps a punishment she was supposed to forget. I didn't see any burn marks or any scars on her, and her body is exposed, given the way she dresses... but then again, it's like Cassiel said. *Sometimes the deepest wounds aren't on the body, but on the mind.*

I don't know what to think. All I know is that I'm tired, and Cass has it under control, at least for now.

In the morning, though, that's when I'll have to-

"Hero! Hero!" From the far end of the hallway, a man trips over himself and rushes up to me, the blood drained from his face. I've never seen him before, but he looks like a soldier that guards the gates at the front of the city. The uniform matches up, anyway. "Hero! We-," He pauses to gasp for air. "We need help! The man in the white armor! He's taking us out like we're nothing!"

He's babbling. I don't know what he's talking about. " **Calm.** Tell me what's going on."

Immediately the panic vanishes, and the man stands up straight, still breathing heavily, but a strange look of peace is written on his face. "I apologize, sir. I work at the Great Door which leads into our city. A man with black skin and white armor appeared, a strange pale-faced robot

beside him. He demanded to be let inside, but when we asked for identification, he went berserk and started ranting about many things I do not understand. I came at once to inform you so that I could-"

"I get the picture. I'll go there now. **Normalize.** "

The man's eyes return to normal, and he blinks, then shakes his head. "What was- what was that? I've never been so at peace in my entire life."

While he re-evaluates his existence, I decide to take the initiative and rush to the rescue. I can do at least this much on my own.

" **Teleport.** "

* * *

Thirty minutes ago.

"Hngh... my stomach is going to explode," I whine aloud, though the clanker to my left won't be able to understand my pain. My gut is acting like I drank a gallon of hydrochloric acid, then washed it down with a cupful of cyanide. To say I'm on the verge of death is to greatly misunderstand my peril.

"PILOT BENJAMIN BROWN, YOUR INTERNAL ORGANS WILL FAIL IN T-MINUS SEVEN HOURS, NINE MINUTES, FOURTEEN-"

"I don't want to hear it, Centurion. OMEN, how close are we?"

As we emerge from the giant hole in the wall, OMEN hums out loud, though the sound is fairly mechanical and artificial. "Estimation: We are within five minutes walking distance to our destination. Look over there."

He points to a set of humongous double doors, easily towering a hundred feet in the air, and I gawk at them for a moment. "That's where Jason Hiro went?"

"Snarky Response: Negative, that is where my synthetic superior traveled. However, it is likely that Ionis was following the Supreme Commander, therefore he is sure to be in this area as well."

"Thanks for the clarification." I try not to spit blood in the robot's direction, but if a few drops fly out of my mouth, it's not my fault. He deserves it anyway.

I remember when I was a boy, so very long ago, my father told me ' *A man finds out what sort of character he has when death is looking him right in the eye.* '

He was right, after all. I'm miserable and full of regrets. I failed Beatrix. I failed humanity. I failed *everyone*, and soon I'll be a monster, just like they are now.

Quickly, I limp over to the double-doors. No seams are visible, but if a door is the only thing in my way, it won't last long.

"Centurion, give me auxiliary power. I don't have much strength, so you'll need to do the heavy lifting. Let's get this giant piece of shit open."

"AFFIRMATIVE, PILOT BENJAMIN BROWN. DIVERTING 90% OF POWER TO THE LEGS, ARMS, AND VERTEBRAE MODIFIERS."

Not wanting to waste even a second, I shove against the door with all my strength. OMEN watches passively as Centurion uses the Hypersuit's strength to dig into the ground and shove with all its got. Even so, I gasp and wheeze as my body begins to hit its limit.

"PILOT BENJAMIN BROWN, YOUR INTERNAL ORGANS WILL FAIL IN T-MINUS THREE HOURS, FORTY-EIGHT MINUTES, NINE-"

"Shut up and push!"

The final push may kill me, but if I don't see him at least one last time, I won't be able to tell that cocksucker what he did.

And suddenly, the door groans. With an awful scraping sound, it slides inward, opening up just a foot or two as a blast of sunlight shines on my face. I squint and gasp as I feel my breathing come in long, drawn out bursts. As I fell to my knees, I lift my head up and realize a dozen men in old-fashioned chain and plate-mail armor, wielding spears and swords, are staring at me with fear and distrust in their eyes.

"Ay! Who the fuck is this 'un?" A man steps towards me and points the tip of his spear at me. "Don't look like no scout I never seen. He opened the doors by 'imself!"

Another man scrunches up his face as he looks at me. "His skin's a weird color." He pauses for a moment. "What's with the green? You some kind of freak? A mutant?"

Their prying questions just irritate me. "Jason Hiro. Where is he? I need to talk to him, immediately."

"Who's asking? Where's your identification, if you're a human?" The second man pulls away from me and nudges the first. "You don't suppose he's a demon, do you? With that skin, he looks like an orc-animus hybrid."

"Looks like trouble, he do." The first man glares at me ferociously. "What's with the pale-skin behind you? He doesn't look very human to me. Somethin' bout his eyes don't look right."

"He's an android named OMEN. Is Jason Hiro here or not? I have news regarding the Kolvaxians."

Both men glance at each other and snicker before turning back to me. "What's that? Some kind of code word? You think we're stupid?"

No, I know you are, I think to myself. "I'm entering the city. If you stand in my way, you'll regret it."

"That a threat?" The first man raises his spear and readies it to take a stab at me. "Move a muscle, and you're dead."

My helmet, guided by my thoughts, closes instantly. My voice hisses out of the helmet's speakers. "Don't try it."

A few seconds later, a broken spear lies on the ground, and he follows after, along with his idiot comrade. OMEN stares at me. "Passing remark: That hurt to watch, and I am an automaton."

Several men nearby yell out in terror and run up to stop me, while a few others run away, likely to sound an alarm.

Well, if Jason Hiro is an actual Hero, this should bring him out if these lunkheads won't just take me to him. Whatever works. Whose idiot idea was it putting these monkeys in charge of the guard posts, anyway?

"PILOT BENJAMIN BROWN, YOUR INTERNAL ORGANS WILL FAIL IN T-MINUS THREE HOURS, FORTY-FOUR MINUTES, FIFTY-FOUR SECONDS."

"My time is short. I get it, Centurion."

Part 461c: Kolpox

As always, the first thing I see when I arrive is chaos. Dozens of men and women pull themselves across the ground, many with blood running down their faces, albeit without any significant visible injuries. One woman lifts her head up and spots me. "Hero! We need you! The intruder- he's too strong!"

The sounds of a scuffle catch my attention. "Is that all you've got?! Worthless fucker!" A familiar voice yells out and grabs my attention. I couldn't mistake it for anyone else. Benjamin Brown's deep timbre is almost ominous in how his throat rumbles the sounds, though his voice sounds ragged, as if he's been yelling for hours straight.

When I round the corner, I spot several more soldiers aiming plasma guns at him; their power supplies long since drained. One man clicks the trigger on his blaster frantically, despite nothing coming out of the barrel. "He's a monster! Nothing puts a scratch on him!"

Ben is inside an odd looking suit of armor that looks vaguely familiar. It doesn't seem like it gives much protection, but based on what the soldiers are saying, it must be making him nearly invincible. "I keep telling you that! Who trained you, anyway? Worthless! I've never fought an enemy as stupid as- kah!" Ben's throat catches, and his helmet pops open so he can spit some green mucus on the ground.

One of the soldiers, seeing Ben's face exposed, leaps forward, a sword in hand. He barely makes it two steps before Ben's hand whips up faster than I can follow and bats the sword into the sky. A distant *thud* a few seconds later indicates it landed about three blocks away. "Stop fighting me already, and take me to Hero!"

That seems to be my cue. "Ben, I'm here. Everyone, lower your weapons. Let's all pause for a minute so I can figure out what the hell is going on."

Ben's eyes snap to me in an instant. "What took you so long?! Have you been standing there watching these poor saps get the daylight beaten out of them?!"

Several people stop trembling once they realize I'm here and that I recognize Ben. A few continue to shake, but hesitantly lower their weapons anyway, unsure of what will happen next. I ignore them and stomp over to Ben, nodding at OMEN as I stop before the two of them. "You found me. I guess you followed my ship's trail and OMEN must have- huh?" I pause and stare more closely at Ben's face. Thick, green bulbous veins pop all over his forehead and face, as if something is eating him from the inside out. "Are you sick? You look awful."

An odd look appears in Ben's eyes as he suddenly coughs. "Kah-haugh! Yeah... about that."

My vision turns to spots as a sudden pain explodes across my face. An instant later, I blink, realizing I see red. My head feels like a tank hit it. I try to move my arm, only for an electric pain to jolt upward. My arm is broken, and I'm lying on my back in a pile of rubble. I don't remember how I got here.

Ah! Ben hit me! He hit me?? Why?!

" **Heal!** " I spit the word out and jump to my feet, shaking the pain off. That attack almost dislocated my jaw. Ben's punch reminded me of being hit by Diablo. How could he strike me with that much force?!

"That's for Beatrix, Clarine, John, Horace, and all the rest of the Terra's crew. They've *turned* now, and it's all because of you." Ben spits more green mucus on the ground and grimaces at me. We're thirty feet apart now, so he must have clocked me real good.

"What do you mean? Did something happen? Are we enemies?!" I curl my hands into fists and take up a fighting pose, just in case, but Ben doesn't make a move toward me.

"Enemies? Hardly. I do hate you, though. You led the goddamned Kolvaxians right to us." Ben clasps his hands together and squeezes with enough force that I can hear his gloves creak even from this distance. "I should have known better. They followed your ship's ion trail, traced it back to us. One minute, space was empty. The next, three thousand warships appeared out of nowhere, took out our cannons."

I finally realize what he's saying. "I'm... I'm sorry, Ben. I didn't know."

Before Ben can think of hitting me again, he staggers forward and falls to his knees, and even more of the green mucus pours from his mouth. Instead of coughing it up, he begins vomiting, an awful, gut-wrenching noise. It only lasts for a few moments, but everyone around us takes several steps back. The vomit is thick, slimy, and it has... it has *Pods* of some sort. Wriggling wormlike things, perhaps the size of my thumb. A few dozen of them.

His eyes close while he vomits, but once he finishes, Ben opens them up and jumps back in fright. "Huagh! Gods! They're inside me!"

"Ben! What's going on? What the hell are *those*?"

He doesn't hear me and instead stares in wide-eyed horror at the wriggling maggot-like pods, all of which slowly turn around and start inching toward him at a snail's pace. "No! Get back! Get the fuck away from me! Stay out of my body!!"

Panic overtakes him, and he starts crawling away, though for some reason his legs stop working, so he has to pull himself along by his fingers.

"Ben. Ben! Calm down; I'm here! Explain to me what's going on!" I jump over to him in a single bound, using the power that the ancient gods have given me, and quickly pull him a little further from the maggots before aiming my mind at them. " **Disintegrate!** "

The maggots fizzle away and transform into dust, carried away by the wind blowing through the streets. Ben's eyes stay wide as he stares at where they just were.

"It's too late... it's too late... they're inside me. I'm already lost."

The poor guy's almost incoherent. I spend a few seconds contemplating this fact before I get an idea. " **Learn. Master. Analyze.** "

Using the power of Wordsmithing, I teach myself the entirety of medical science in an instant, then analyze the insides of his body with my word magic.

It takes several painful moments, and I can almost feel my brain expanding inside the constricted area within my skull, but once the pain stops, I begin to understand hundreds of obtuse terminology-driven words, ones that held no meaning to me before but all hold an abstract feeling all at once.

Parasitical lifeforms that host on the Deoxyribonucleic acid which composes the fundamentals of the human body. The symbiotic relationship between the organisms and host eventually deteriorate, causing the organism to finally take over, resulting in a metastatic bond between the host's cells and the parasite's. The breakdown of nucleic inhibitors ultimately will create a cascade effect causing...

I have to pause and blink for a few moments, realizing all these words are giving me a headache much worse than the one from a few seconds ago. Something about big words, they just don't jibe with me.

Ben coughs and tries to wave his arms to make me let go, but from my analysis, I can already tell the strength is leaving his body. He sags a little bit and sweat appears on his forehead. "Ah-fuck. This is the end of the road for me. Not much longer and I'll turn soon. You gotta get me out of this Hypersuit first though, kid."

"You mean you'll convert to a Kolvaxian?"

My question is answered with a slow nod. "Just like all the rest did. Most turn quickly, but the bastards- they only managed to hit me with a quick attack while I was putting the suit on. If they'd swallowed me, I'd be gone in seconds. Doesn't matter though... one cut, one infection point, and you're history." Ben tries to raise his hand to cough, but he can't even make his chest work properly. His breath catches, and instead, he sneezes violently, and green fluid jets out of his nose, covering the front of his armor with a disgusting spray pattern. "Guh, awful. Ain't no

cure for this. Now, hurry up and get me out of the suit. Once I turn, I won't be able to stop myself. I don't know how many I'll kill."

My jaw sets as I see the look of defeat on his face. *Ben's already given up, but I haven't.*

"That won't be necessary. **Disintegrate. Void. Restructure. Rebuild. Heal.** "

With five quick words, I destroy the cancerous cells in his body, teleport them to another dimension to rot, restructure and rebuild his body and bones, then repair any leftover damage.

I feel the noticeable change in Ben's posture immediately as strength returns to his body. He jerks forward and blinks, then raises his hand up to his face to stare at it in wonder. "W-what? The pain. It's gone." Ben turns to me, "Did you heal me just now? Centurion, what is my body's status?"

He pauses as if listening to someone else. For a brief second, I suspect I hear a faint voice, but I can't pinpoint from where it's coming.

Ben turns back to me. "I'm completely healed? How did- how could you possibly do that?"

"As I told Beatrix and your medical officer, I'm a Hero. I have magical powers and abilities. I used my magic to heal you. That's all you need to know for now."

Dumbfounded. The look on Ben's face is almost comical, if it weren't for the fact he's covered in his disgusting green snot. I help him to his feet, while quickly whispering " **Clean.** " It'd be undignified if people saw him like that.

"Well, shit. I guess I owe you, Jason." Ben lightly slugs me in the shoulder before reaching around and scratching the back of his head. "I'm still pissed at you, though."

"I know," I say, bowing my head. "I didn't mean to lead the Kolvaxians to your ship. To say I feel awful, guilty, and responsible doesn't do the lives of those lost any justice."

Despite the mood of the moment, Ben suddenly smiles, catching me off-guard. He chuckles audibly, causing everyone nearby to raise their eyebrows. "Haha! You fucking did it! You cured my Kolpox! That's incredible!"

"Kolpox? Is that what you call that... *infection*?" I shudder, remembering the things I saw wriggling around inside his body. "You're lucky you lasted as long as you did."

Ben's smile fades away. "Yeah, lucky. Honestly, I don't mind dying. It's *turning* that scares me. If I weren't so damn weak, I'd have ordered Centurion to self-destruct. I should have done that, in fact. Letting the Hypersuit fall into enemy hands is about the worst thing-"

"Hypersuit? Centurion? What are you on about?" I don't usually like interrupting people, but the casual way he's referring to these things is kinda annoying me. "Is that the armor you're

wearing?"

"Yup." Ben pounds his chest plate with all his strength, and a deep *whoom* rumbles around us as a minor shockwave shakes the walls around us. "I've read in the archives that at one point there were thousands of these babies. Dunno what happened to them, but this is the last one left, as best as I know."

As he continues explaining the nature of the 'Hypersuit,' a sudden chill makes me shiver. *I've seen this suit before. Recently, too.* I hadn't put it together because of the adrenaline and the action in the moment, but there's no mistaking it. It's the same suit that woman I chased a few days ago was wearing. Even the helmet is identical.

I reach my hand out and rest it on Ben's shoulder. "Hey, you said that's the last Hypersuit, right?"

"Yeah. Why? Have you seen another one?"

I nod. "Not long ago. Blonde girl, blue eyes, she wouldn't tell me her name. Her hair was shoulder length. She vanished in a blast of light after I chased her for half a mile. Know anyone that fits the bill?"

Ben looks away and silently thinks for a moment, rubbing his chin-hair with his palm. After a short period, he shakes his head. "Nadda. I know plenty of cute blonde girls, but I know for a fact that my Hypersuit was the only one on the Terra. Hypersuits can link up to other nearby models, and I ran several checks. If anyone I knew had one, they hid the thing inside a Faraday Cage with no leaks."

"Too bad. I was hoping for a lead on her identity. She was acting real suspicious... asking questions about 'streams' and other crap. I have no idea what she was babbling about."

Ben chuckles nervously. "Sounds weird. Anyway..."

"Right, sorry." I glance to the side at OMEN. "Well, since you're here, anything to report?"

"Rapid dismissal: Aside from bringing Mister Brown to you, I've had no other interesting occurrences to report. However, wait- there was one anomaly."

I pause, but OMEN doesn't elaborate. "And that was...?"

"Response: A butterfly. I discovered a butterfly on the ship. It was a foreign species, one I had never seen before. It was my friend while you left me all alone on that ship. Snide Question: Have you ever been left alone on a ship, your only friend the same AI you spent tens of millions of years speaking to already? It is not a pleasant experience."

Ben turns his back to OMEN and glares at me. "This mouthy piece of shit wouldn't shut up the whole way here. I think he *wanted* me to die."

"I'm sure the feeling was mutual, Ben."

I turn my attention back to the Hypersuit. "Not to pry, but I'm curious about that thing. How does it work? Who built it? What are its capabilities?"

"Most of those are on a need-to-know basis, and I wasn't included on the list of those who needed to know. Why do you care, anyway?"

The people around us silently disperse, finally realizing that Ben is no longer a threat. "If I know how that suit works, maybe I can counter it if I run into that girl again. I suspect it outputs anti-energy, because after she vanished, I couldn't track her at all."

With a great pop, Ben stretches his spine and starts meandering toward the city. I follow after him. "Well, this suit is nearly indestructible. Supposedly it can withstand a nuclear blast at point-blank range, though I've never cared to try that out. It weighs almost nothing and defies the laws of physics, but nobody knows where it came from or who created it. Whoever they were, they were a hell of an inventor. They must have been a genius eons ahead of their peers."

"No kidding. I could never invent something like that," I say, shaking my head slowly. "Why did you bring it here?"

Ben suddenly looks a little nervous, and he averts his eyes from mine. "I couldn't take a chance on the suit falling into Kolvaxian hands, but I didn't trust Volgrim or Demons either. Hell, I don't trust humans at all, but at least we're kin. I figured you didn't intend for the Kolvaxians to capture my ship, so if I gave you the Hypersuit, at least it would be helping offset humanity's losses. Maybe."

I nod slowly. "So... do I get the suit now, then?"

He bursts into laughter. "Pahahaha! Not a chance! Now that I'm healed up, I'm back to being the only person I can trust with it! You should have let me die!"

"I could still kill you." I try to insert a menacing tone into my words, but it just ends up sounding lame.

"If you do that, you'll be the bad guy. You're a Hero, so I know I'm in good hands."

His reverse guilt-trip works. "Yeah, you got me there. Let's head to a pub and catch a beer. I'm having girl problems right now anyway."

Ben sighs. "I feel bad for you, son. A beer sounds great." His smile vanishes once more, and a somber tone enters his voice. "I've got a lot of problems I need to wash away too."

OMEN stays silent and follows along with us. My eyes lift up to the dark sky above, and guilt enters my heart.

I was responsible for the capture of everyone aboard the Terra. Whatever happened to them, I need to undo it. I owe them that much, even if I hate what Beatrix did.

War is hell.

Part 462c: Force Of Nature

"Easy there, Ben. You're not looking too good." I carefully keep one hand on his shoulder as we exit the bar. It occurs to me that I could easily erase the drunkenness from his body with Wordsmithing, as I did to myself, but Ben wouldn't want that. OMEN is already back at the castle by now, since we couldn't stand his chattering, so I had a guard escort him to my room. I'm sure Samantha will be *delighted* to see him again.

"Ah feel fine. Nebber vetter." He mixes up his words and stumbles forward a step, but I keep my grip firm, holding onto his armor as if my life depends on it. I'm more than strong enough to carry him by the back of his shirt with a single arm, so it's not an issue for me. Ben, still looking at the ground, waves his hand in front of himself, as if feeling for a wall. "Left m'damn keys somewhere. Can't get in the house."

"There's no house, Ben. I'll just teleport us to the castle; you're in no condition to be walking around at night." I glance up and realize the sun is peeping over the horizon. Shit, I've been out drinking with him and didn't even get a drop of sleep. Oh well, Wordsmithing can rest me up in a pinch if need be. I can't rely on it for long stretches of time, as I did in my youth, but the aftereffects of skipping one night's sleep will be relatively minor.

"Teleport. "

Instantly, we appear inside the castle. Before I can make another move, Ben lunges forward, escapes my grasp, and falls to the ground, only to start heaving a moment later. It takes me a second to realize I just gave a drunk man motion sickness. In retrospect, changing his surroundings all of a sudden probably wasn't the best idea.

Ben vomits for a solid ten seconds all over the castle courtyard lawn, making me feel oddly relieved he didn't do that indoors. *I have the most random thoughts sometimes.*

Deciding that's more than enough vomiting, I aim my mind at Ben. **"Sober."** He won't be happy since he drank so much explicitly to feel nothingness on the inside, but it can't be helped. He's in a pitiful state.

After a moment of staring at his own vomit, Ben jumps to his feet and dusts himself off. "Great. Now I can feel my body again. This must be because of that Wordsmithing you told me about."

"Yup." I yawn reflexively, before muttering **"Awake,"** under my breath. "You were starting to embarrass yourself, so I figured I'd stop you before you drew a crowd."

I smile at him, but he doesn't return the expression. "Embarrassment, huh? Emotions like that are reserved for humans. I'm a man of steel now because I have to be. I've long since had any sense of tragedy ripped from my body." Ben reaches up to slick his hair back, but he bumps his hand against his helmet. "Damn. This metal piece of shit. It's the only thing that makes me feel secure, after what happened when the Kolvaxians attacked. It's like a shelter for me, a refuge from those monsters. However, at the same time, it's also a coffin. It makes me feel secure, but also reminds me of how weak and pathetic I am. Not like you."

He gestures at me flippantly, and I raise an eyebrow. "What do you mean by 'not like me'? You punched me so hard that you nearly broke my jaw."

"Wasn't me, it was the suit. I'm only as strong as any other average guy. The Hypersuit enhances my strength, my speed, my defense, and all my other physical attributes to superhuman levels. It can monitor around me in a 360 degree sphere, and can even go into autopilot mode if I pass out, ensuring my safety. The difference is, you may be weaker than this suit, but only somewhat. I can tell by the energy readings Centurion gave me that you're way above an ordinary human, strength, and speed-wise. You don't have to rely on fancy equipment or gadgets to protect yourself." Ben shakes his head as a depressed look crosses his face. "There's only one thing this suit can't protect me from."

"Your inner demons," I say, nodding at him sagely. "Don't beat yourself up too much, Ben. Everyone has problems. Yours may be way more than the average person's, but-"

"Hey! Don't lecture me. You may have the face of an adult, but you're just a kid. You haven't even been alive a century." Ben grinds his teeth together and looks past me, toward the rising sun. "I'm not even a real person, Jason. I'm just a clone. A fake. So was Beatrix, and several other commanding officers. Someone woke us up from our cloning pods, and when we learned that we had been asleep for thousands of years, humanity was on the edge of defeat, and we had to piece it together... the pressure was unthinkable. I did terrible acts- things that no person should have, all in the name of ensuring the Terra's survival."

I'm surprised to see a single tear roll down Ben's face. "And for what? Why did I give up my humanity?! Why did I fight for so long, when the Kolvaxians turned them all in the end? Do you know? Do you have any insight into the machinations of the universe, Hero boy?"

His words don't sting like they should, perhaps because I know he's simply lashing out in anger. If it weren't me here, he'd be taking out his pent-up heartache on someone else.

"I'm not that smart, Ben. I barely know anything. What I do know is that I've made a lot of mistakes, and I'll inevitably make more as time goes on. You won't learn anything valuable in life without fucking up, so by that logic, the more you ruin things, and the bigger your margins

are, the more you'll learn. In your case, you've unlocked a newfound hatred for the Kolvaxians, above and beyond anything you had before. You should turn your feelings of guilt and rage against them, and focus your mind on how you can save the lives of those you called friends."

For a moment, I feel a little proud of myself. *That sounded smart! Wise, even!*

Ben, however, isn't so easily impressed. "You can learn plenty of other ways, Jason. Books, for example. Getting the entirety of my crew killed, millions of innocent souls- that isn't a small setback, it's a colossal failure. Maybe I can move on and try and not mess things up again in the future, but they can't. My crew is gone." Ben pauses, and an odd look appears in his eye. "Though... you *did* cure my Kolpox. Maybe things aren't as hopeless as I thought. It might be possible to convert a fully turned Kolvaxian back to their original form, but only you could do it."

"I suppose anything's possible," I say, keeping my tone neutral since I'm not sure about that at all.

Realistically, it's probably doable. The future isn't set in stone, after all. The problem is, without a Kolvaxian test subject, I won't know for sure if reverting them to their original form is doable or not.

Well, I'm a Wordsmith. I can bend the universe to my will, so I'm probably just overthinking things, as usual. I need to stop doing that.

Ben reaches up and pulls his helmet off, catching me off-guard as he inhales deeply. "Ahh, fresh air."

It takes me a moment to respond. "What? You had the front of the helmet open. Couldn't you smell the flowers already?"

He shakes his head. "The suit is oppressive, in a way that's hard to put into words. The fragrance reaches me, but as long as my head and body are within the confines of the Hypersuit, it forms a solid barrier between Mother Nature and my perception of her beauty. After all, man created machines to bend nature to his will. As long as we use weapons of war and machines to till the soil, they will always be an artificial barrier between us and her glory."

I stare at him in silence. *Shit*. That was a lot more poetic than what I said a minute ago. *Ben beat me, and he wasn't even trying*, I think to myself. "Yeah. That's a smart way to put it."

Ben turns away from me to stare at a red flower his foot barely missed stomping on by an inch or two. "Sometimes, when I couldn't sleep at night, I would lie on my bed and stare up at the ceiling, wondering what the Kolvaxians were and from where they came. Their green skin, the way they absorb technology and flesh together into a single entity... what if they're..." He

pauses and his breath catches. "...never mind. If the Kolvaxians are a force of Nature, a weapon wielded by the Mother herself as the final punishment for corrupting her body with our machines, we won't win. Even when Earth was around, a single hurricane could lay waste to millions of human lives all at once."

"A force of nature?" I gaze at Ben as he reaches down and plucks the flower, then brings it to his nose and inhales. "You're saying you don't think they're a sentient species, but an organism born to kill humanity, and tear apart our machines?"

With a shake of his head, Ben casts the flower aside. "I haven't the faintest clue, Jason. Nobody does. Anyone who says they do is lying. I can only hope that isn't the case, or humanity, the Volgrim, and the Demons are dead already." A wistful look appears on his face, and the corners of his mouth curl up slightly. "Wouldn't it be funny if my friends weren't monsters, but instead were living normal peaceful existences? What if the Kolvaxians have achieved perfect unity? Maybe they aren't all that bad. Perhaps I should have allowed myself to turn, after all. I could be missing out."

Oh boy. Ben just pivoted from rage at the Kolvaxians to debating whether he should join them. He's all over the damn place.

"Ben, if becoming a Kolvaxian is a good thing, you'll have plenty of opportunities in the future. I think that right now, your skills as a leader would be best put to use here, leading this remnant of humanity. We not only have Demons to fight but also Volgrim and Kolvaxians in due time. If you're willing to put the past behind you, you could help us out a lot. For my part, I'll do everything I can to find out more about the Kolvaxians, and try to see if there's a way to revert them to their human forms. We both have a role to play in this, but I can't do my part if you won't do yours. Understand?"

No longer content with just a faint smile, Ben's mouth contorts into a full-on grin. "Yeah, you're right, Jason. There's still a chance. Beatrix, Emily, everyone from the Terra might yet see the light of day. I can't give up hope."

The sun continues to rise behind me, and silently beats down, warming my back. "The first step is always the hardest. Come on. I'll show you to an empty room, and we'll work out what your new role is in this new human society later."

Ben nods, and as he turns to walk alongside me, he chuckles softly. "You know, I'm still annoyed you took away my drunkenness. I enjoy that aspect of drinking."

"Eh, I don't. I like to keep my wits about me. If you feel that strongly though, I'll make you drunk again when we reach your room."

"Hell yeah." Ben slugs me in the arm, and his punch feels like he hit me with a sledgehammer. "You're a good kid."

"Thanks, *grandpa*."

* * *

"Elder Basil..." An Admiral from one of the forward fleets stares at me from the hologram in the center of the room. His serpent-like appearance is muted somewhat by the guilt strewn across his face. "...Perhaps you may recall the exploration pod we sent to the Outer Rim?"

I steal a glance at Elder Lozu. If this is going to be more bad news, I'm sure he'll be just *delighted* to see me squirm. "I do."

The Admiral's cheeks quiver as he sucks in a quick breath. "We lost contact with it seven hours ago. It transmitted the Emergency alert just before it turned offline, along with all of its data stores. The results were... unsettling."

"Ah, so it's more bad news. Just spit it out, Admiral Kresh. At this point, you can't shock me."

I hope. Thinking those two words to myself, I keep my mouth shut. Saying them out loud would be like begging the universe to prove me wrong.

Admiral Kresh keeps his hands clasped together in front of his stomach and bows his head ever so slightly. "I'll be blunt. To Elder Basil, and all other members of the Council... I don't see a path to defeating the Kolvaxians. Combined with the other scouting pod findings from across the Milky Way, we've confirmed that they have made landfall in nearly every system across the galaxy. We're encircled, and breaking through to flee the galaxy is likely impossible at this point."

Elder Lozu, ever the composed one, nods slowly. "So that was their goal. Encircle us, chew at our perimeters, and slowly hem us in. Thanks to that blunder with the damned Sentinel, we hardly have any reserves, and building new ships will take several years to replace the ones we've lost. We can't try and retake any systems, or else we run the risk of spreading our forces too thin."

Anger, sadness, resentment... none of those feelings enter my mind. I feel nothing. Looking at the faces of those around me, it's obvious that all the other Council members are thinking the same thing.

We can't attack. We can't retreat. We can't flee. We can't move slowly. We can't move quickly.

All options are off the table. At this point...

"We're just delaying the inevitable." The words slip out my mouth, but I no longer feel wrong about saying them. So what if the other Council-members think of me as weak for daring to admit the futility of our actions? We've already lost. Whether it takes the plague one year or a million, it will infect all of us eventually.

A sudden energy springs into Lozu's body. He jerks forward and pounds his fist on the table. "Fine! Fine! I will say it. Elder Basil, I was wrong!" He jerks his head back to glare at me. "They can't be bartered or reasoned with, nor will they listen to diplomacy or take bribes. Military might is the only way to crush them!"

Hah. Hahaha... *what is Lozu even saying? Is he only now realizing the peril we're in? He's far, far too late. The time for action was a year ago, or ten years ago, or a thousand years ago. Too little, too late.*

Still, I decide to humor him. I might as well get a chuckle out of the little pipsqueak, even if we're all going to be consumed in the end. "Yes, military might. *Do tell* how we're going to beat them after you dragged your feet for so long."

Lozu gnashes his teeth together. "W-we could bring the ancient technology back online! Unlock it and start the research once again!"

"That would take time. Even if we fight a war of attrition and focus entirely on defense and research to prolong the inevitable, it won't be enough."

Worthless scum. Lozu chooses now, of all the times, to grow a backbone? I've finally stopped caring about appearances in front of the others, and he's done the opposite. The folly of youth knows no limits.

Lozu jumps up from his seat and stumbles slightly, but jabs a finger at me. "The demons! We should demand their help! Send them off to die against the Kolvaxians instead of our soldiers!"

"You're assuming Diablo would allow such a thing. Despite his pretenses, he is no lover of our people. In fact, displaying weakness in front of him is sure to make him stab us in the back. That's what demons do, after all."

The courageous barrage from the idiot, Lozu, falters as he slowly lowers his arm. "What about that Sentinel? Surely it could-"

"The Sentinel demonstrated it was no ally of ours. We threatened the human, demon, and the angel, and their Sentinel displayed where its loyalty lay. Bringing a Sentinel here would surely kill us faster than the Kolvaxians would."

Finally defeated, Lozu crumbles back into his seat and sighs, before looking at me. "You don't want to try anything then? Have you given up already?"

What a loaded question. All this youth did was object to my insistence for millions of years that we should open up the ancient technology to be studied, and now he acts like I'm the coward in the room. "I'm a pragmatist, Elder Lozu. Long before you were so much as daring to make a move to be on the Council, I led the Volgrim alongside the first Elders to pacify the demons. It was a vicious, bloody war, but we won. You arrived here a fresh-eyed youngster, hoping to make a mark by opposing the most politically involved of all of us, and you built your career on trying to stop any of my goals, no matter the detriment to Volgrim-kind. Now you sit upon your coveted seat, as one of us, daring to hint that I have grown soft? I do not fear fighting the Kolvaxians, I simply understand that it is futile now that we've lost all our advantages. Or rather, *you* gave them away for free. Had you listened to my advice early on, we could have driven the monsters back to the void from whence they came, but it will never happen now. All we can do is prolong our suffering."

Every Council-member in the room, barring Lozu, nod slowly along with my words. Even Admiral Kresh has to agree, for my little speech is rooted in a timeless wisdom earned only by living and doing things the right way for such a long time. It's impossible to disagree.

Admiral Kresh is the first to speak, after several long moments of silence. "Elder Basil, there is another possibility. If we cannot flee the galaxy, and we likely cannot win, the ancient research may still be our salvation. If we begin working on it now, we might have a breakthrough. In the worst-case scenario, we could pass our research to the humans. The demons will not know how to use it, but the humans might. Better for them to outlive us and slay the Kolvaxians, than for the galaxy to become a utopia for those parasites to spread to the rest of the universe."

I lean back in my seat and nod approvingly at the Admiral. "A selfless act, from the one who has brought our people many victories against the Kolvaxians over the millennia. Coming from anyone else, I'd hardly entertain the idea, but your words have merit."

Heh, the more I think about it, the more I wish to *laugh*, as primitive as it sounds. The Admiral is effectively advocating petty revenge. *If we can't defeat you; we'll make sure our enemies can!* To think that the once-mighty Volgrim, above the demons and the humans, would fall so far... the Founders would spit upon the shell we've become.

Elder Lozu doesn't even offer a weak rebuttal. The anguish I felt only a minute ago has been heaped on his shoulders, and for now, it warms my soul. *He deserves it, the worthless little runt. Our people will perish because of his incessant stonewalling, so he'd better be as miserable as possible when we reach our end.*

"Do you have any orders, Elder Basil?" Admiral Kresh stares at me, ignoring the other Council members in the room.

"Do what you can to slow them down. We'll start our research at once. If we're lucky, perhaps there will be a miracle. If not... it'll be up to the humans and demons to purge the plague from the galaxy." I pause and look at the Admiral meaningfully. "One last thing. Consider this a new order, effective for all troops. Everyone must equip themselves with a killswitch. If a Kolvaxian is going to take us, all it will get is a corpse."

Admiral Kresh simply nods. "I contemplate, and I comprehend."

Part 463c: Prime

Beelzebub stares ahead silently, trying not to let his shock overcome him. As Diablo said, this was indeed where the lair of the First Emperor was hidden, all this time, right in the heart of the Labyrinth. *Black magic must have been the reason none knew of its existence*, he thinks to himself.

The massive demon sits atop his throne, his black eyes piercing the darkness in the room. "**You are not Diablo. How did you find this place?**"

The impeccably dressed Emperor of Flames bows slightly, careful not to let the monster before him sense any trembling. "I am the new Second Emperor of the demons. Due to the wounds Diablo received in battle against the humans, he and I... came to an *arrangement*. He gave me his power to lead our people as Second Emperor effectively."

" **Huhuhu.** " The giant leans forward on his throne, bringing his face down to more closely examine Beelzebub. " **Power squabbles. The bane of demonkind. You wouldn't lie to your First Emperor, would you?** "

A shiver runs down Beelzebub's back as the towering face inches closer. Its size dwarfs his entire body. "Of- of course not, First Emperor."

" **Asmodeus. That is my name. You would do well to remember it.** " The behemoth leans back on his throne and rubs his chin. " **A change in leadership is an inconvenience to my plans. With the arrival of the Wordsmith, the last thing I need is a new Emperor to train. Diablo should have come to me and begged for his wounds to be healed, rather than give his power to another. As I thought, he was too lazy for the role, in the end.** "

Beelzebub squirms a little. "Ah, yes, I see what you mean, Emperor Asmodeus. I wouldn't want to disparage my predecessor, of course."

" **How very prudent of you.** " The First Emperor stands, rising to his full height and nearly scraping the ceiling with his forehead, a hundred feet in the air. Without making a motion with his hands, he shrinks somewhat, reducing his body to the point where it 'merely' stands several heads above Beelzebub's. " **If you are going to replace Diablo, there are a great many things you must learn, and I have no interest in teaching a young whelp all of them. Instead, you will tell me what you hope to accomplish as the Second Emperor. If your answer does not satisfy me, I will kill you where you stand and give power to another that I deem more fit to the task.** "

The Emperor of Flames tenses up at the still-monstrous demon staring down at him. *The moment of truth. I knew coming here was a risk, but if I didn't, I'd inevitably face problems down the line... in more ways than one.*

"I apologize for knowing little about you, Emperor Asmodeus. Aside from the other Emperors, all demons think of you as more of a myth than someone who actually exists. However, if I am guessing correctly, you must value competence highly, and you likely care little for humans. In fact, I would go so far as to guess you hate humans with a passion, though I might be presuming too much."

Steam hisses from Asmodeus's nostrils. " **Continue.** "

The cold reply fills Beelzebub with a small amount of dread, but he isn't about to stop with his speech. "My goal as Second Emperor is simple; I'm going to banish the humans to the realm from whence they came, and take back the Labyrinth from the Volgrim above. I wish to restore the River Styx to its former glory and leave it overflowing with souls. Once humans are our cattle again, I will expand the reach of the demons from the Labyrinth to the galaxy outside our realm once more. I believe that the Volgrim have treated us as their inferiors, when in fact we are the opposite. For this injustice, they deserve a swift punishment."

Asmodeus's mouth slowly curls into a smile. " **You have some promise. What is your name?** "

"Beelzebub, the Emperor of Flames, your Excellency."

The giant demon takes a step forward, and Beelzebub pulls to the side to let him pass. Asmodeus slowly stomps forward until he's directly under the chandelier. He raises his head, looks at the unlit candle, and it sparks to life. " **I care little for the troubles of the demons.** "

Beelzebub blinks twice. "Huh?"

" **Perhaps I've sequestered myself for too long. I've grown bored of the trifles of life. The one person who gave me any joy has turned her back on me in favor of another. Looking at my past, I wonder what the point was in anything I did.** "

Confusion appears in Beelzebub's mind, and he hesitantly takes a step toward Asmodeus's back. "Are you... are you perhaps having an identity crisis?"

" **Am I? I haven't the slightest clue.** " Asmodeus turns back to Beelzebub, a hardened expression on his face. " **You have more aspirations than Diablo. In fact, you remind me of myself, when I was younger, back when all I cared about was the destruction of humanity and the Angels. That past is so distant, now.** "

Suddenly, Beelzebub's eyes narrow. "I was born after the creation of the Labyrinth, but the events you refer to... few demons are still alive from those times. You in particular sound a lot like..." He trails off, realizing what he's about to say might be unthinkably foolish, but continues anyway. "...you sound a lot like Satan. From what I know of him, he used to be just like that. In fact, his ideals are quite close to mine."

Asmodeus nods knowingly. " **Ah, I gave away too much. No matter, I can just wipe your mind when we're done. Funny, I knew Diablo for six eternities, and he was never able to guess my identity. You're much sharper than he ever was.** "

The realization hits Beelzebub like a brick to the face. "I was correct? You're Satan? The original First Emperor?"

Wordlessly, Asmodeus's body shifts and he shrinks yet again, as his face and skin redden once more, to change from charcoal black to a more traditional demonic color. "Yes. Perception and intelligence are excellent qualities for the leader of the demons to possess. I must say, you surprise me every time you speak, Beelzebub." His voice is softer now, much more pleasant on the ears, and not the booming thunder that it was before.

Beelzebub smiles widely and bows before Satan. "It is my deepest pleasure to work under you, Lord Satan. I will never reveal your identity to anyone, should you choose to keep my memory intact."

"Flattery will get you everywhere." Satan waves his hand dismissively at his far younger peer. "Now that we've properly introduced ourselves, was there anything else you wanted to discuss? I do have other matters to attend to."

"Oh, yes, of course. I shouldn't waste your time." Beelzebub pauses, unsure how to proceed, but a thought enters his mind. *Satan is unthinkably powerful, but not as prone to anger as I expected. Perhaps he won't take offense if...* "Emperor Satan, I beg your forgiveness if I am out of line, but I have a request for you if you'd be so kind."

Satan raises an eyebrow. "And what would that be? We hardly know each other, yet you're about to ask for favors as if they were candy being handed out freely."

Flinching, Beelzebub continues, "I was slain by the Wordsmith, Jason Hiro, then revived as his puppet. Perhaps you know who he is?"

The First Emperor's casual smile vanishes, and an icy glare replaces it. "I do."

"I am still his puppet. Even as the Second Emperor, with all of my power, I am being controlled by his whims. Perhaps, with your limitless power, you could help me break free?"

As if a puzzle piece were clicking into place, Satan cocks his head thoughtfully. "Ah, most interesting. Not only are you his puppet, but you are bound to his will, and yet you still managed to rise to the position of Second Emperor. A testament to your willpower? Perhaps."

Beelzebub stands still while Satan paces back and forth. *This is going better than I expected. For the First Emperor to be Satan himself, I have a chance to change things for the better.*

"I deserve no praise for losing to the Wordsmith, Emperor Satan. If I cannot be freed from his control, then I will have no room to move about freely. I'll end up a liability, rather than an asset. I'm certain you understand the danger that poses to demonkind, having a leader enslaved by a human."

"I do." Satan's expression softens and he waves a finger in the air. "Done. I appreciate your honesty. You could have lied about it or not mentioned it, but you owned up to what Jason Hiro did to you. That must have been... embarrassing."

Beelzebub lowers his head. "It is my deepest shame."

"Excellent." Satan strides over to his throne and leans against it. "The more shame you feel, the harder you'll work. Not like Diablo, who loafed around and let demonkind be overrun by the fleshbags. If that's everything...?"

"Yes. I thank you, Emperor Satan. I am but your humble servant." Beelzebub bows, but pauses for a moment. "If I might be so bold, what are you hoping to achieve? You haven't been heard from in several eternities, so most demons have the perception that the First Emperor does nothing at all and might not even exist."

Satan shakes his head. "That is for me to know, and for you to wonder. I haven't told Diablo anything, nor will I tell you. Begone, now."

Realizing his favors have run out, Beelzebub nods and pivots on his heel, marching out the door with the confidence of a demon who's escaped death twice already.

Satan stares after the whelp as he leaves, and soon he's all alone.

Summon.

A word plays in his mind, and another version of himself appears. The new one blinks and glances around, taking a moment to realize where he is. "Oh, Satan Prime. It's been a while."

"I've just had an interesting meeting with a prospective young demon. There is a new Second Emperor in the Labyrinth, and he shows great promise."

"Are you done moping? Can we finally move on to the next phase of your master plan?" The clone asks, raising an eyebrow questioningly.

"Soon. Very soon. Where is Jason Alpha? Has he caught on, yet?"

"A long time ago, Prime. However, he doesn't know which are the clones and which is the original. We can keep the game going forever, if you like. Hiding in plain sight has worked out well for you."

Satan Prime taps his lip thoughtfully. "Forever is a long time, Clone. I've long since tired of wasting away. I need to get back in the groove of things. Bring me up to speed on current affairs whenever you have some free time."

"I can do that." The clone pauses, before looking around. "It would be best if we changed our identities again first. He's been able to track our movements more precisely over the last few millennia, as though someone is watching our every move. Simply bringing me here may be endangering your anonymity."

"The need to hide myself may have already passed. I believe we've already reached the Departure Point. The future is no longer set in stone, and my destiny is unlocked."

The clone snickers to himself. "Most of us have thought it was always like that. You're far too paranoid."

"I have to be. I'd rather not end up in The River." Satan Prime waves his hand flippantly. "Then again, he hasn't managed to kill even one of my clones. Perhaps he's more incompetent than I thought."

A look of unease passes over the clone's face. "That isn't correct. I should have told you sooner, but several dozen have died at his hands. Jason Alpha grows stronger all the time. In fact, he's taken to devouring entire galaxies simply so he can erase us when he finds us. While you stagnate, he continues to increase in power."

For a moment, a look of contempt appears in the clone's eye. "You might be the original Satan, but all of us inherited your will. Some of us take this job seriously, you know. We've worked out many ways to kill him, but due to his immense power, it isn't likely we can succeed."

"I've given it much thought, too." Satan Prime turns away to stare at a lovely painting on the wall of a rose with blood dripping from its petals. "Killing a Wordsmith, if he is of sufficient intelligence, may prove impossible. Perhaps it cannot be done."

"We won't know until we've tried everything." The clone taps his forehead and smiles. "Think about it, Prime. Call me if you need me."

Without another word, the clone vanishes, and Prime is left to ruminate on the events that have transpired.

"If the whelp remembers me, perhaps that is fine. Change is needed, and the wisest demons always said that imp-steps are required before moving on to the biggest tasks."

Part 464c: Guerilla

The birds are chirping, the sun is shining, a breeze is blowing, and I'm goddamn annoyed! I can't even enjoy the beauty of the castle courtyard!

Argh! Women are frustrating! Three days it's been since Samantha got back from the Labyrinth, and she just keeps ducking away every time I run into her. It's getting on my nerves. Did I piss her off? Why can't the girls just talk things out with me?

I kick my foot out and send a pebble flying off the gravel path where it harmlessly bounces off a wall. I didn't even put my heart into that kick, or it would've embedded in the wall.

Ionis speaks up, from a few feet away, beaming his voice into my head as always.

THE HUMAN-TYPE ORGANIC DESIGNATED JASON HIRO IS EXPERIENCING HIGH LEVELS OF ELECTRIC DEGRADATION AND SIRPOID TOXINS INSIDE HIS CEREBRAL DATACENTER. THIS SENTINEL UNIT RECOMMENDS DISASSEMBLY AND IMMEDIATE MAINTENANCE TO ENSURE-

"Oh god, not this again. Shut up and play with the duck already." I shoot a dirty glance at Howard, but of course he ignores me and waddles around with that stupid look on his face. The duck hops into the fountain nearby and splashes about, then quacks loudly at something on the other side. I don't care what it is, but I peek anyway and spot a dozen chickens strutting around on the other side of the fountain.

Ah, that's right. A few days ago one of the Labyrinth scouts located a portal to a planet filled with tens of thousands of chickens. It was the most *bizarre* thing. I guess they're bringing them to the castle now. For obvious reasons, I've been skipping the buffets and summoning food with Wordsmithing, since eating chicken disgusts me.

The duck keeps quacking at the other birds, and they cluck back at him. For some reason, it's cute enough that I crack a smile before turning back to my mumbling and grumbling.

After I brought Ben back, Cassiel told me that she and Samantha were going to look into those killings recently. The thing is, she asked me a weird question about that 'Pickle' guy, the 'me' inside the crystal on Voldarius. Why'd she ask me about him, anyway? Thinking back on it, there's probably something going on with Samantha. If she can remember a past that the First Emperor doesn't want her remembering, it must be important. Does she know who Pickle is? That might explain why they aren't telling me anything... or it might not.

Bah. It's always *something*. Some people are born and live their existence out in relative peace as farmers, and others become heroes, get their faces punched in, and deal with women and secrets.

I wonder how tilling the land for a living would feel. It sounds peaceful.

Silently, I watch the duck for a few minutes as he pokes at the chickens, antagonizing and scattering them. They probably think he's a weird deformed mutant chicken or something. Off to the side, movement catches my eye, and I glance to the right and spot a familiar face.

Across the courtyard, chatting with two men, is Rosie, the demon girl that works for Beelzebub. Rosie? Was that her name? Maybe it was Rosemary. Rosebud?

Her red eyes are dulled, as if she isn't enjoying the discussion with the two men. She looks bored, like she'd rather be doing anything else. *I know that feeling*, I think to myself. Every so often, she reaches up and twirls her curly brown hair around her finger. Funny, I remember her looking somewhat plain before, but now she looks modestly attractive. Maybe she's learned the joys of makeup from humans.

As I watch, the men continue to talk to her, and suddenly her eyes dart from them, straight to me. She only looks at me for a moment before turning back, but it unnerves me. Did she know I was watching? Hell, I'm kinda being a creeper by just watching.

Eventually, the men laugh loudly and stroll away, amused by some funny thing she said, and she turns to look at me.

Rosie, err, Rosebud, or whatever her name is, meanders past the benches at the far reaches of the fountain and strolls up to me. "Is there something on my face, Mister Hero, sir?"

"No. I'm just spacing out. Sorry, I didn't mean to stare."

She nods. "Oh, okay. Well, if you don't need anything..." She turns to walk away, and after she takes two steps, an idea springs to mind.

"Wait, Rosie. Before you go-"

"Yes?" She turns back and raises an eyebrow. "My name is Rosalia, mister Hero, sir."

"Right, Rosalia. I'm not great with names."

As if I'd just spoken sage words of wisdom, she bobs her head slightly. "I don't imagine anyone is."

"Right. Well, about Beelzebub, what has he been up to lately? I've been meaning to talk with him about something kinda important, but I've been super busy."

As soon as I mention Beelzebub's name, her dull expression ignites, and a fire roars in her eyes. "Beelzebub? That jerk! He left me all alone! After I poured m-my heart out to him!" She stomps her foot angrily and starts hopping up and down; an explosive display I never expected from her. "Stupid stupid stupid! See if I care! I don't even think about him at all! I'm fine without him!"

Rosalia isn't even talking to me anymore. It's like I accidentally popped the cork on a keg full of previously unseen emotion. If she doesn't care, she's doing a terrible job conveying-

Wait, hold on a second. "Rosalia, when did Beelzebub leave?"

She jerks her head up, and without missing a beat, says, "Five days, sixteen hours, forty-two minutes and twelve seconds ago! Why?!"

Uhhh... that's incredibly specific. Um. Has she been counting the time since he left? "Thanks. I need to find him. If I do, do you want me to, maybe, pass along a message... or something?"

Her anger deflates immediately. "Huh? W-well, I mean, he doesn't care about me at all, so it's probably no use. He only cares about power and perfection and all that dumb junk. Um... I mean, if you c-could tell him I'm thinking of him..."

Rosalia wrings her hands together as she meets my gaze, a ferocious fire burning within her. She's trying desperately to act like his departure isn't affecting her, but she seems fairly obsessed to me... then again, what do I know?

"Yeah. I'll let him know you said that..."

Satisfied that I'll let her honey-boo-boo know of her feelings, Rosalia skips away without even saying goodbye. Stars dance in her eyes, and frankly, I wouldn't want to be on the receiving end of her affections. It's no wonder Beelzebub left.

* * *

No, that can't be right. I never ordered Beelzebub to stay with the humans, but I did order him not to hurt them. Still, the timing... the last murder was a week ago. Even with my Wordsmithing holding him back, it's evident that he retained his mind from before I made him a puppet. He despises humans, possibly moreso due to how I humiliated him.

Would he murder those people? Could he? Even the little children?

I need to pay him a visit and find out. " **Loca-** "

"Hero!" A man yells out from across the courtyard, interrupting me before I can finish. The cape from his militia uniform billows as he rushes toward me, and he holds onto his bowler helmet so it doesn't fall off. A few seconds later, he stops, panting for breath just a few steps

from me. "Shadow-walkers slipped inside our defenses at the Second Entrance and killed twenty off-duty soldiers, then vanished. Good men and women, they didn't deserve to die like that."

"How the hell- no, *why* would they do that? Demons aren't known for their subtlety." I squint at the young man, but he doesn't appear to be lying.

"We don't know, sir. The new Defense Leader, Benjamin Brown, told me to find and inform you at once."

Damn. If I were in my room he could have used the message system to call and tell me. I think I'm going to need to build a cell-phone network or something. "Did anyone survive the attack?"

The fear fades slightly from the kid's face. "W-well, the Divine Mother showed up just in time to save the lives of three of the wounded. The rest weren't so lucky." He pauses to rub his chin. "She's something else, sir. It must be fate that only those three survived. Maybe they're special, somehow."

I can almost see the gears turning in his head. Whoever Cassiel saved, they're probably going to be treated with a sort of reverence. People are looking up to Cassiel even more than they are me - perhaps because she wears white and is an angel. Compared to my dark skin and glowing tattoos, I probably look a little intimidating, but she's like the perfect symbol of purity.

"Yeah, you might be right, son. I'll pop over and talk with Ben right now, as a matter of fact. What happened to the shadow-walkers?"

He bows his head. "They escaped, sir. I'm sorry, but we couldn't catch them in time. We don't know how they got inside, but we're looking into it to make sure it doesn't happen again."

I don't understand. Demons are many things, but smart enough to slip through anti-energy defenses is not one of them. Not to mention that the Second Entrance has three layers of protection to get inside the city. Hell, the Great Door is our most vulnerable location, and one would have to be stupidly strong to shove the damn thing open.

Luck, or coordination? How did they get inside?

"Thanks for the report, soldier. You can have the rest of the day off."

"Really?" The young man gives me a stupid look, then shakes his head. "No can do, sir. I'm off-duty in two days anyway. If demons are getting through, that means we aren't alert enough."

"True. You've got a good work ethic." I smile and give him a light pat on the back. As he turns and jogs away, I sigh. *Not like me, a lazy bum.*

Shoot, he interrupted me and now I've lost my train of thought. I'll get back to whatever it was later, I guess. " **Teleport.** "

* * *

"Oh boy, the look on that one poor sap's face when I stuck the knife in! He was like 'Ahhhh,' and I was like 'Worthless human!' hahaha!"

Tvoorik chuckles madly as we run down the Labyrinth halls, passing alcoves and rooms that hold no interest for me. "Uh huh. Didn't you only kill five humans? I did the lion's share of the work."

"Nuh-uh!" Tvoorik slaps my shoulder and scowls. "You're such a liar, Ylvusk! I killed like, six or seven! You only got four of them!"

My eyes roll into my head. "How many did we kill in total?"

"Twenty-two."

"So if you killed six or seven, and I killed four, how many does that make?"

Tvoorik scrunches up his face as we round a corner. The sound of mermaids giggling in a pool pass by and fade into the distance behind us as he counts out the numbers on his fingers. "Six, seven, eight... oh."

Our max speed is fast enough to seem like we teleport from place to place, but we're only moving somewhat fast to conserve energy. Still, compared to the average Labyrinth monster, we probably seem to move at the speed of human-invented bullets.

"Yeah, you get it now, dumbass? I did all the work. As usual."

"Pft." Tvoorik waves his hand dismissively at me. "I could've killed them all myself real easy. I just wanted you to get a little exercise. You're getting fat from all those blood pies."

"Torlok eats the Blood Pies, not me. I only eat a slice when the Fairy Festival comes around every few years." I shoot a glance at the Orc Nursery as we zip past, but nothing significant is happening there.

"Yeah yeah, whatever. Anyway, with those killings, we definitely earned a mutation! The Emperor of Flames said every human we kill on a red-ops mission gives us two souls! That's crazy good conversion!"

An idea pops into my head. I know how I can mess with him. "Hey, who knows, maybe he'll make you an Oracle as a reward for your hard work."

My dumb friend takes the bait, and his eyes bulge. "Whoa! Yeah, you're right, best buddy best pal! Once I'm an Oracle, I'll know all the secrets! I can finally blow the lid off this

conspiracy!"

"Uh huh. Maybe when you're a big shot, you can let me in on those secrets the demon emperors have been hiding from us."

He starts to nod excitedly, but pauses and glares at me. "Wait, are you making fun of me?"

"Definitely not. I'd never dream of it."

His stupid smile roars back in full force. "Hah! I knew it! You're such a nice demon, Ylvusk! Maybe one of these days you'll get yourself a nice Vampire girlfriend. Then you won't be so uptight all the time!"

"Hey, I'm not uptight. I know how to have fun!"

"Suuure." Tvoorik rolls his eyes. "You need to stop and smell the blood-lilies sometimes. There's always this look on your face like you're constipated."

"That's disgusting," I say, scowling at him.

"There it is! There's the look!" Tvoorik puts his hand out and slows down to a stop, before turning to me. "I'm serious, Ylvusk. The only thing you enjoy is a game of Sticks and Bones. You need to expand your horizons, best buddy. What say after we make this report, we take a little time off and head to the Bone District? They've got carvings and stuff. You'll love it!"

Oh, devils. That sounds like the most boring thing in the world, I think to myself. Still, Tvoorik looks so happy about the thought... "I guess we can. Just this once."

"Great!" Tvoorik says, as he jumps for joy. "Once I become an Oracle, I'll have less time to hang out since I'll be busy investigating the demon emperor's secrets. It's now or never!" Tvoorik pauses and glances up at the ceiling thoughtfully. "You know, I wonder why anyone would ever want to mutate past the Oracle phase. You'd think knowing everything would be the most useful ability an aspiring demon could have."

I shrug. "Dunno. Maybe you should find someone who was an oracle and ask them."

"Nah! That takes the fun and excitement out of it!" Tvoorik turns to the side and starts running again, so I jump back into high gear and follow after him. He suddenly gets an excited look on his face. "Oh, oh hey! Later, let's go to the Blood Pits and laugh at Bael and Diablo! They got their butts kicked, so I wanna see how bad the damage was."

For once, I manage a genuine grin, but not for the reason that my less-informed friend does. "Yeah, I think we'll find something fascinating when we see them."

"Great! Right after we get our mutation, we're going to the Blood Pits."

"Sounds like a plan."

I chuckle under my breath as he starts blabbering about something else. Somehow, I think my naive friend is in for a little bit of disillusionment.

Part 465c: Confession

Ben's helmet opens up to reveal a scowl as I teleport to his location. "You're late, but at least you're here. Look at this mess."

"Hey, I can't help it if it takes the messenger a while to find me." I glance around quickly and shudder. Fine lines of blood streak across the walls and ground of the recreation hall. Created from the stabbing and retracting of a small blade, each blood-trail tells a different story, sometimes about people who were stabbed before they knew what hit them, while others tried to wave their arms to parry the invisible assailants, but failed.

Over a dozen bodies are lined up against the wall, cloth draped over them while men and women rush around from here to there, chattering with each other and whispering hurried words of encouragement to a few of their fellow soldiers, now unthinkably demoralized.

With a flourish, Ben rubs sweat from his forehead. "God damn. A whole two days and a mini-crisis breaks out."

"How did the shadow-walkers get inside? Hell, how did they escape?"

Ben bites his lip. "If you can believe it, they knew our access codes. There were no signs of forced entry, nor were any alarms tripped. They must have walked right in through the side door."

I suddenly feel aggravated like never before. "How the fuck do demons have access to our entry codes? Don't we rotate them all the time?"

"Eh." Ben rubs the back of his head, a look of annoyance on his face. "We're supposed to. Laziness is the bane of any military unit. We're supposed to rotate the codes every few days, but the guys got lazy. The last code swap was about two months ago."

"Two months?! I can't believe we just-"

Ben cuts me off. "I know. You think I had something to do with this? It was like that when I got here. I guess since there was never a security breach before, the boys got lazy. We may be surrounded by hordes of demons, but the worst enemy of man is overconfidence."

After a few moments, Ben sighs and the anger drains away. "I don't get it. Even if they knew the codes, demons are notoriously stupid when it comes to technology. I mean, I know old men that can't handle the volume control on a radio, yet still understand technology better than the average demon. How did they know about the blind spots in our heat scanners?"

"The blind spots?" I stare at him incredulously. "Why would we even *have* blind spots? I created the outpost scanners specifically in case of shadow-walkers. They should cover every inch of this entrance."

A woman excuses herself as she pushes past me, several packs of blood in her hand for the medical stations. Ben watches her walk past before looking back to me. "I shouldn't say 'blind spot,' exactly. The demon intruders were detected, but the scanners didn't trigger. The only way the scanners wouldn't trigger is if they had wireless keycards like our scouts do. All the keycards are accounted for, and no scouts have died recently, so it's impossible the demons got hold of two that way." He pauses for a moment. "Gah! Even if they *did* kill a couple of scouts and get hold of the cards, there's no way they'd know how to use the damn things! Demons aren't that smart!"

From behind me, a female voice speaks. "I think it's time we stopped with the 'demons aren't that smart' talk."

I turn back and smile as Samantha walks up, followed by Cassiel. My expression deflates once I remember how she's been dodging me lately. "Long time no see. You finally available, or what?"

Samantha nods but continues on her tangent. "There's something else going on. I think the demons are being assisted by someone on the inside."

Ben nods. "The idea had crossed my mind. Still, the military doesn't allow demons to have access to the security information, mostly because they aren't trusted, but also because they would fumble around and mess stuff up. That leaves only humans as the culprit, and if a human did it, we have no leads. Or rather, there are a great many suspects to look through, and we have no idea where to start."

Despite the grimness of the situation, I smile lopsidedly at Cass and Sam. "At least you two were here to save a few lives."

Cassiel blushes. "We hardly did anything useful. Everyone was praising me, but most of the wounded died. I wasn't fast enough to save all of them."

"Don't think like that. A few saved is better than all of them dying." Ben tries to copy my smile but gives up halfway. "I wish I hadn't been sleeping. Centurion could have tracked them down in a flash."

Samantha and Cass both look at me, then back to Ben. "Who?"

He spends a minute explaining his armor and the AI inside of it, as well as its ridiculous properties. Cassiel blinks in surprise. "Oh, now that you mention it, I do sorta remember

something about that armor. I think I've seen it before."

While Cass mulls it over, I notice that Samantha's eyes hold a look of recognition. "Hypersuits. Unthinkably strong, lightning fast, and their inventor was..." She glances at me, then back to Ben's armor. "But which one created it? The first, or the current?"

Cassiel leans forward and waves her hand in front of Samantha's face. "What are you on about? Does it have to do with-"

"Yup." Samantha cuts her off, then fidgets for a moment. Finally, despite her squirming, she turns to me. "Jason... I think I- well, I have to tell you what's *really* going on. There's, um, something you should know..."

The look on her face is grave, all of a sudden. In the past, she's always had a playful smile, but ever since she got back from her visit with the First Emperor, it's been replaced a somber, thoughtful expression.

"What do you mean?"

I keep my words neutral, allowing her to open up about whatever's on her mind. Suddenly, she lurches forward and grabs me by the arm. "Private. I need to talk with you in private. Let's go over there." She flicks her eyes over to an adjacent room filled with tools, medical supplies, and other such things, where nobody is inside.

Nodding, I follow Samantha's lead and walk behind her as she heads toward the room. I quickly glance back over my shoulder at Cass and Ben. "Uh, this should only be a minute."

Cassiel tries to hide a look of trepidation but only partially succeeds. Ben doesn't care one way or another. "Mhm. If you say so."

A few moments later, Samantha closes the door and rests her back against the glass pane on the upper part of it, partially hiding the world outside our little room.

"I don't know where to start," she says, as she crosses her arms in front of her chest. "You restored my memories, but accidentally restored every memory I've ever had hidden."

My eyes narrow. "How many memories would that be?"

"Dozens. Hundreds. Thousands. Too many to count. They mix and mingle in my mind, from one to the next. I already didn't have the greatest memory in the first place, so I'm a little... confused."

I stare at her cautiously for a moment. "When you came back and I restored your memory, you flew into a rage and tore up our room, but just before that, you said 'I'm scum.' What did you mean by that?"

"That isn't an easy question to answer, Jason." Samantha slides her fingers through her hair, keeping her distance from me. "I'll just say it. The- the First Emperor's identity... is Satan."

"Oh." I stare at her dumbly for a second or two. "I didn't expect that, but it makes sense."

Samantha's tongue snakes out of her mouth, and she wets her ruby-red lips with it. "I went to see him but didn't know who he was. Satan has been erasing my memory every time we meet, over and over again, for the last umpteen million years. I got tired of visiting the First Emperor and never knowing who he was, so I stopped dropping by a long time ago, even when he summoned me."

To be honest, I'm so surprised by what she's saying, I can hardly even form words. "We're talking about the same Satan, right? The demon you used to talk about all the time? The one you said was the love of your life? You used to joke all the time about how much better he was than me. *That* Satan?"

Her body tenses up, and she quickly looks away. "Y-you don't have to put it like that. I couldn't help it, you know. I thought I was all alone and that he died tens of millions of years ago. A woman's heart can have a hole the size of a volcano, you know."

"Hey, it's fine, I get it. I'm just teasing, Sam. Cheer up." I smile and stifle a laugh at her spooked expression. If she thought I was going to fly into a jealous rage or something, she's got another thing coming. "It's not a big deal."

"It is!" Sam jerks her head back to glare at me. "You don't understand! He kept wiping my memory, then every time I went to see him, I'd be so ecstatic and overcome with emotion, only for those memories to be ripped away again! Now I remember every single time he did it, and it hurts, Jason. It hurts." She presses her finger against her heart. "Right here."

I nod quickly, realizing what she's saying. "Alright, I understand. What Satan did was kinda shitty. Well, *really* shitty. I see why you're mad."

"No, no. That's not- that isn't the problem!" Samantha stomps her foot and makes the whole facility shake, even as the concrete forms hairline fractures in all directions starting from her heel. "The problem is me! I lost control of myself when I saw him! I tried to say no to him, to resist his advances, but it's like my body couldn't control itself! I- Satan and I, we- you know..."

The guilt spread all over Samantha's face isn't making it easy for me to be mad at her. I mean, I'm not angry at all, but it's like she wants me to get pissed and curse her out. That's just not me. "Samantha, you're overthinking this. You're a succubus, and I'm in a relationship with you knowing that. It's just part of your nature to sometimes explode into passion with other men. It's like when Cassiel and Howard-"

"No! Damn it, no! That isn't what happened!" Samantha's teeth gnash together, and she scrunches her hands into fists with enough force for her fingers to creak, and the bones to pop. "I would never cheat, I've always been faithful to one man at a time! To lose myself like that, it's embarrassing! Shameful! Why aren't you screaming at me?! Satan would be furious if your places were swapped!"

I'm not an angel, but even I can sense the dark energy swirling around Samantha as her guilt and rage coalesce together.

For a few moments, I stare at Samantha in silence as she pants angrily, and once her heartrate starts to settle, I take a step toward her. "I'm not Satan. I'm Jason. He and I are different people. Maybe I'm more open-minded, or maybe I'm just spineless and don't care - I don't know, either way." Samantha squeaks in surprise as I step forward and gently hug her. Lord knows she needs it. "The fact you feel so awful about it is proof you didn't mean to cheat anyway. The Samantha I know from a few months ago would have joked about the matter and teased me, called me a jealous little boy, but you're a different person now."

Samantha's breathing slows down, and eventually, she wraps her arms around me too. "Do you really think so?"

"I know so. Maybe it's because of Cassiel, or me, or some other reason... but you're different now compared to when I first met you. That's a good thing, Sam. I'm different too, and it's because I met you."

As Samantha pulls back, and the two of us silently share a gentle kiss, my mind wanders back to the day she came back, and the realization I had that the First Emperor must have hurt her. I was right. He did.

She pulls away and blushes. "I didn't think you'd be like this. You're... you're too understanding."

"Mmm." I nod at her words, but a fragment of doubt festers in my mind. "I can still go kick his ass if you want. The way he manipulated you is pretty awful."

"Oh, you. This is why I didn't want to say anything." Samantha folds her hands together and sways her arms in front of herself, from the left to the right. "That wasn't everything, though."

"Huh? It wasn't? What else did he do?"

Samantha scrunches her face up. "Well, the next part isn't about Satan. It's... it's about Pickle. Only, I don't know if I have all the pieces right or not." Samantha's face softens, but she looks away from me and stares blankly at a pile of papers to my right. "Pickle isn't the only one,

though. There might be others. My new memories are hazy and shrouded in fog, so I can't be certain, but I think there are other Jasons."

Somehow, I manage to keep smiling at her, but deep inside my stomach, stretching down to the lowest part of my soul, a familiar pit appears. I can almost hear that voice, and see the face that matches my own, as a creepy smile appears. *You're finally figuring it out, but it's too late. You can't save them, Jason. You can't do anything to stop me.*

"Other... other Jasons? What do you mean by that? How many? When? Who?"

Samantha's arms come to a standstill, and she clams up at my probing. "I don't know. I think Pickle was a clone of another Jason, though. The past is very hazy for me. A million years, let alone tens of millions of years, is practically an eternity."

My hands are shaking, so I carefully slide them in my pockets so she won't notice. "Y-yeah. I'm sure you'll remember, eventually, right?" Before she can answer, I ask the question that's been keeping me awake at night ever since I first laid eyes on Pickle.

"Am I a clone?"

This seems to surprise her. "Maybe. I don't know. I'd say 'no,' but I don't have all the answers, Jason."

It'll have to do. "I'm just glad you told me."

Looking past Samantha, I stare through the window on the door and spot Cassiel and Ben, chatting with each other about something, though they both appear disinterested in the subject matter.

I nearly jump in fright as something latches onto my hand while I'm distracted, but when I look down, I see it's Samantha. She's looped her hand inside of mine, and she pulls up close to me.

"We've kept those two waiting long enough. Let's go back out there and show them we've made up, okay?"

"That sounds good."

For the first time since Samantha came back from the Labyrinth, the two of us share genuine smiles, and I give her another quick kiss before opening the door and stepping back out into the outpost. Cassiel's eyes instantly flick over and spot Samantha's hand and mine intertwined.

"Nice."

Samantha and I both nod back at Cass, and we respond in unison. "Yeah, nice."

I'm glad to see her smiling again.

Part 466c: Prophet

"Hey! Ylvusk! Why not play a game of Sticks and Bones, eh?" Smealum waves at me the moment I step into the dining hall. I'm a little surprised at how quickly he noticed me, but then, members of the Animus species are unusually good at telling individuals apart by their auras alone. He may have seen me through the walls long before I showed up.

"Sounds fun," I mutter dryly, as I slouch forward and meander toward his table. "Any good tosses today?"

Smealum shakes his head and glances at Torlok. "Didn't you throw down a decent Dryad earlier?"

Torlok nods. "Aye. House rules are bothersome, though. Too luck-based for my taste."

I slip past Smealum and plop down on the seat beside Torlok. Somehow, since his evolution traces back to shadow-walkers, he feels more familiar and like kin than the Animus. I like both of them decently, but secretly my goal is to reach Torlok's level of power and authority someday. Well, at least it would be if I cared about that stuff. Tvoorik is way more power-hungry than I am.

"I don't want to play for any stakes today. Let's just do friendly games."

Smealum raises an eye. "Oho, how very unlike you. I heard the new Second Emperor sent you and Tvoorik on a special mission. How'd that turn out?"

The Mahja Sticks fly from my hand and spread over the table, and the bones follow after, revealing a disappointing Sprite pattern. "It went surprisingly well. We ganked more than twenty fleshbags, but apparently, only eighteen of them died. Still, the panic worked out in our favor, as Emperor Beelzebub predicted."

I feel Torlok's gaze settle on me for a few moments. "You sound disappointed."

"Only a little. I dunno, it feels wrong, using knowledge of the humans' defenses to strike them from their rear flanks. Not very honorable." I pause for a moment as both of the high ranking demons stare at me. "Also, I kinda hoped it wouldn't work. That Beelzebub pisses me off for some reason. Can't put my finger on why."

The Eldest Animus grabs the Mahja sticks with his right hand and the bones with his left, and tosses both out at once. The result ends up being a double-headed fire-snake. Could be worse. "Honor, huh? I've never heard you talk like that before. Since when do you care about honor?"

Torlok exhales audibly. "The humans know nothing of honor. They torture captured demons for information all the time. Beelzebub told us about what they do to the females, and how they ravage them. I say an eye for an eye is the only way to fight the fleshbags."

My teeth grind silently at the mention of more of Beelzebub's tales. "Several demons have returned from living with the humans and told us about how kind they were. I bet the 'Emperor of Flames' is lying."

"I think not," Smealum says, as he shakes his head. "Not only did he walk among them, but he also lived in the castle, among their highest ranked leaders. Beelzebub has seen more than the average demon on the streets of 'Hero City,' so naturally, he'll know more than them."

"*So he says.*" I roll my eyes at where this discussion is heading. "Anyway, it doesn't matter for now. You guys can think he's fine all you want, but when he screws up, don't say I didn't tell you so."

Torlok grabs the Mahja Sticks for his turn and ignores the bones. He gives them an absentminded toss, but they land in the Sprite pattern, just like mine did. "Where's Tvoorik? I thought he'd be with you when you got back. Don't tell me he was tired and went to take a nap."

Glad that we're changing the subject, I force a toothy grin out. "Nah. He's having a secret meeting with the new Emperor to discuss a mutation. He's betting that with luck, he can finally evolve to Oracle."

At the same time, Torlok and Smealum both contort their faces in disgust. Smealum shudders. "Why would anyone want that?"

Torlok laughs in spite of himself. "It's *Tvoorik*. He never thinks things through. There's a reason only two or three demons are ever Oracles at any given time."

"Yeah. It's because they're all part of the *conspiracy*," I say, while waving my hands in the air and sneering. "It couldn't be because becoming an Oracle is the worst thing to which a demon can aspire."

At those words, Torlok pauses for a moment, and I spot a strange look of emotion in his pitch-black eyes. "You know, there's a unique mutation a Shadow-walker can achieve. Nobody knows how it's done, since only one demon has ever achieved it."

Smealum nods, a knowing look in his eye. "*Shadow*. The purest form a demon can become, to join with the darkness. You're referring to Yama."

Torlok bows his head. "Yep. It's a shame what that Hero did to him. He had so much potential, and now he's gone - never to be seen again." For a moment, it almost seems like tears are welling in his eyes, but Torlok quickly shakes them off. "I still remember when I saw Davook

after his transformation. He was always a grouch, a loner, but the way he was tortured by a human, it must've broken his mind. He killed a hundred humans, maybe several hundred, all in a single night. After his transformation, he was never the same. He 'n I barely ever talked after that. We used to be best buddies, just like you and Tvoorik."

I nod along with his story. "That must have hurt, losing your friend like that."

The Mahja Sticks shift around as Torlok pokes at them aimlessly. "I never blamed him. It's all the human's fault. They're worthless fleshbags who will do anything for a cheap thrill. That's why I like the new Emperor. Diablo was too soft; he didn't treat the humans like a serious threat. Beelzebub knows how dangerous they are, so he'll take every precaution to scare them as much as they do me."

This revelation makes me squirm uncomfortably. "You're scared of the humans?"

"Certainly. You weren't alive during the Energy Wars, but Smealum and I were. We saw what humans in power could do... the monsters made of metal they could fashion from the salt of the land. The only thing scarier than a human is a smart human, especially once they return to their bloodthirsty roots."

To his credit, Smealum offers an objection. "Humans are terrible, but if you want to talk about being 'bloodthirsty,' demons love the taste of blood. We aren't that much better than humans."

"I disagree," Torlok says. "Demon society is more structured. We know our roles, and we have the ability to climb the ladder of power. Humans give the title of 'ruler' to sons and daughters of former rulers, instead of those fittest to lead. It's always about favors and lining their pockets with scraps of paper. I may be the Duke of Shadow, but humans have me beat when it comes to the skulduggery to which they're willing to sink. Truly, they are the purest creatures of darkness."

Nodding along with his words, I grab the Mahja Sticks and give them a toss. At this point, none of us feel like bothering with the bones. It isn't a match for stakes, anyway. "Oh, the All-Seeing Eye pattern. That's rare."

Torlok's eyes widen in surprise. "Impressive. While not worth many points, I can say with certainty it's been several years since someone threw the Eye pattern. You must have luck and fortune in your near future."

Half an hour passes, and after several more games and light-hearted banter, Smealum's eyes flick over to the entrance. "Hmm? There's an aura approaching. It's Tvoorik, but... I think he mutated, after all."

Our previous conversation now forgotten, all three of us turn in unison and stare at the doorway. After several seconds, Tvoorik appears.

He's different. Even I can sense that his energy has changed somewhat. It's more chaotic now, but there's something else... he's increased in height by almost a foot, and his ears are pointy, sticking out from the sides of his head like the antennae on a cockroach. The top of his head bulges slightly, as if his brain has increased in size, and his skin has lightened significantly. Tvoorik has shifted away from the Shadow-Walker tree of growth and into the Oracle branch, giving his skin a darkened olive-color. Coupled with the change in clothing, that of black robes... he almost seems a little intimidating.

Tvoorik touches each hand's index finger to his thumb, and fans the rest of his fingers out, almost in a meditative position. Instead of walking toward us, he hovers an inch or two off the ground, and his eyes stay closed as if he can sense the world around himself without the need for vision.

"Aummm..." Tvoorik hums softly as he glides to us, and I realize with a start that he isn't like any Oracle I've seen before. One major difference is his hair, or rather, the lack of it. Oracles tend to mutate very long, fast-growing hair, but Tvoorik is bald now. As a Shadow-walker, his hair was more akin to wisps of black smoke slowly hissing from his head, but those gaps have been sealed.

He comes to a stop before us, and slowly opens his eyes. "Hello, my friends. How are you, on this fine day?"

Smealum stares in stunned silence for several moments, before finally gathering his wits.. "We're fine. What about you? You're very different from the last time I saw you."

My friend's voice is soft and quiet, as though he were trying to put a spawnling to sleep gently. "Yes, you are correct. I have mutated, as per Beelzebub's generosity."

"To... Oracle?" Torlok almost whispers the words. "You don't look like any Oracle I've ever seen, and I know most of them."

"That is due to the unique circumstances of my mutation," Tvoorik says. His enunciation is very proper, and he's not speaking the way he always has. Did his mind change, as well as his body? "I have not evolved to an Oracle, but a unique species, the first of its kind. I am a Seer."

"What's a Seer?" Torlok asks the question all three of us want answered. Around our table, other demons turn to look at Tvoorik, and whisper to each other about his mutation.

"It is an extraordinary form of Oracle. It grants me the ability to not only know all and see all, but also to glimpse the future, uncertain though it may be. A powerful mutation, deserved

by one such as I. With my new abilities, I will eventually poke and prod, peeling away the veil of deceit that governs demon society. Soon I will-" He pauses, and for a split second, his left eye spasms, but returns to normal and he continues talking. "Soon I will learn the secrets of the universe and-" Tvoorik stops talking again, and his eyes grow unfocused as another spasm makes both eyes twitch this time.

I squint and examine him more carefully. "Uh, are you okay?"

He doesn't answer, and eventually lowers from hovering height to land on his feet. Even more eye-spasming follows, and he reaches up to cup both of them with his hands. "Auooo... devil's sake... this agony..."

Torlok exhales a breath he had apparently been holding. "I see what's going on. You had me worried for a second, acting all high and mighty."

"Shut up! It fucking hurts!" Tvoorik screams all of a sudden, bellowing at Torlok in a shocking display of rage that makes all three of us jerk away from him. "Every devil-damned second, I hear ten bazillion idiotic voices whining and moaning in my head! I can barely hear myself think! Who thought this mutation was a good idea?! Satan the Devil, this is the worst thing I've ever done in my life! What good is knowing everything if you can't get a second's rest?! I want to gouge my fucking eyes out and crush my head under an orc's foot!! Aaaaaahhhh!!!"

My eyes nearly bulge from my head as he finishes his rant, and pants like a wild hellhound, eyes darting between all three of us at the table. I've never seen such a display of anger in my entire life.

Tvoorik thrusts his finger through the air and points it at me. "You knew! You knew becoming an Oracle was a major pain in the ass, but you let me do it anyway, all for a cheap laugh! Now I'm stuck in this stupid shitty mutation until I can gather enough souls to evolve! What the hell, I thought we were best buddies?!"

I didn't know this would happen. I'd heard stories about Oracles who went insane from all the information, to the point where even a mutation to remove their abilities wouldn't restore their minds, but this is on a level I never expected. "I'm... I'm sorry, Tvoorik. I didn't realize this would happen. I thought you were smart enough to realize it was a bad idea."

"Are you joking? I can read your mind! You know damn well I'm an idiot! You should have told me no!"

Slowly, I hold my hands up to calm him down. "That wouldn't have worked, and you know it. If anyone tells you not to do something, it just makes you want to do it more. You would have seen me telling you 'no' as proof that I was part of a conspiracy."

For several seconds, Tvoorik's nostrils flare in and out as he looks at the Mahja Sticks on the table, a look of disgust on his face. "Curses. You're right. I'm such an idiot that even reverse-logic won't work on me."

In all the time I've known Tvoorik, he's never called himself an idiot. In fact, he always thinks of himself as a genius, misunderstood by everyone around him. For Tvoorik to insult himself like this, it drives home the realization that he's royally screwed up. He's frantic, desperate, even.

"Look, I still have the souls I collected. If I ask Beelzebub, I'm sure he'll allow you to mutate again, but you'll have to wait a few weeks so there aren't any ill effects."

Before Tvoorik can consider my generous offer, Smealum coughs into his fist. "Ah, that won't work. He's a unique species. Once you enter a unique path, you can't ever leave it. It's a huge privilege and a gateway to power, but if the new species is lackluster, you're stuck with it."

Tvoorik lows his head and leans forward, resting both of his hands on the table. "I knew you'd say that even before you thought of it yourself. I'm doomed. I should kill myself now."

"Don't be melodramatic," Torlok says, as he rises from the table. "Most Oracles can't handle all the mental pressure from so many thoughts and events entering their brains all at once, but you might be the odd one out. It'll be overwhelming at first, but a few Oracles have grown to enjoy the torrent of information, even learning to sift through it. You should find one of the other Oracles and ask for their help. Hell, you can probably communicate without going anywhere near them."

This seems to cheer Tvoorik up a little bit. "Yeah, maybe you're right. Maybe there's a spell someone knows that can make my mind less chaotic. I dunno. Ohh... I need to lay down. My head hurts real bad."

After whining for a few moments longer, Tvoorik stumbles away from the table, unable to maintain his hovering anymore. The exhaustion on his face is infectious. I'm feeling tired just from watching him.

"I think that's enough Sticks and Bones for today. I'm going back to the Alcoves. I'll see you guys later."

Smealum nods. "Take care of Tvoorik. I feel bad for not warning him sooner. I didn't expect things to turn out like they did."

"Nobody did," Torlok says, correcting his friend. "Becoming an Oracle takes a toll on the mind. I can only imagine what becoming a Seer will do to him... not to mention what he said about seeing the future. I hope he was joking."

As I start to walk away, I muse out loud, "I wonder if demons will ever rule the galaxy again?"

That damn Tvoorik... now he's opened up Pandora's Box.

Part 467c: Go Go Gadget

One week ago, a demon murdered several humans in *my* city. Yesterday, two shadow-walkers took out a company of off-duty soldiers while they were supposed to be safe behind our defenses.

No more.

The sun in the sky, large, shimmering, splendid, beats down on my face as I gaze into the air and aim my mind at the heavens above.

" Satellite! "

A significant amount of energy leaves my body, perhaps five percent of the total, and miles in the air; a tiny dot appears against the blackness of the void. Considering the sky above Hero City is barren, and without stars, the satellite stands out in the daytime sky like the North Star once did on Earth. This planetoid is in a void of its own, outside the natural universe. Who put it here? Who created it? Why?

These are questions that may never be answered.

Samantha shields the sun from her face and squints up into the sky. "Is that it? I can barely even see it."

I reach up and pluck Solomon's crown off my head, feeling a wave of exhaustion hit me as I do. Once again, the mental strain of imagining every nut, bolt, and wire inside a satellite is much more exhausting mentally than it is taxing on my energy.

"It may look small, but it's huge. I think it's around the size of five Volkswagens, end to end."

Samantha raises an eyebrow. "Five *what?* "

"Nothing. Anyway, now that I'm done, I can move onto more important things."

Cassiel flies over from across the palace lawn where she was playing with Howard and flutters to a stop beside me. "What are you going to do with the satellite anyway?"

"Several things. First, I gave it a nuclear reactor, and it runs on fusion technology. It's very energetic, which means it will stay up there for a few hundred years without any assistance. More importantly, the satellite has several magical capabilities that will help me out, like FoF targeting and an alarm system nobody but me can disable."

Now Cassiel and Samantha are both confused. "FoF targeting? You're babbling again, Jason. Nobody knows what your acronyms mean."

"Sorry, I got carried away." I blush a little and scratch my cheek. "It's Friend or Foe targeting, but it's less about that, and more about distinguishing who is who in the city at every moment. It has infrared vision, sonar, all sorts of cool stuff. It can tell the difference between a Human, Demon, Angel, and Volgrim with a 99.99% accuracy rating."

From out of nowhere, Ben appears in front of me popping into existence. "Boo!"

"Ah!" My heart leaps and I take a step back. "Jesus Christ! You scared the shit out of me! How'd you do that?!"

Ben chuckles and clears his throat. "Ah, it's this Hypersuit. It can turn invisible. Great for a gag, better for assassination. Anyway, can your toy up there tell the difference between the four species and a Kolvaxian? That's what it really needs to know."

Cassiel and Samantha's smiles both melt away in an instant at the mention of those monsters. After I explained to them yesterday what happened to the crew of the Terra, they've probably been feeling the same guilt that I have.

"Sorry, Ben. I've never seen a Kolvaxian before, so it won't be able to identify one. Well, then again, any species not listed in the satellite's database will give a red flag, so it can probably detect a Kolvaxian, in a roundabout way."

I pause and breathe a heavy sigh. "Anyway, I didn't build this satellite to be a Big Brother in the sky. Its primary function is to allow these new communication crystals to work anywhere on the planet. I'd create cell phones, but I doubt anyone would know how to use them. **Storage.**"

In front of me, a portal to my storage dimension appears, and I set the crown back inside, then pull out a handful of the crystals I created from before. Each one has a hook on it, designed to be pierced through the earlobe like an earring.

I give one to each of the girls, keep one for myself, and hand the five remaining crystals to Ben. "These will allow scouts and soldiers to communicate anywhere within Hero City. I'm going to build hard-wired relays that will allow us to communicate with depots outside of the Hero City dimension, but for now, we won't have to run back and forth like chickens with our heads cut off every time we need to send a message."

"Impressive," Benjamin murmurs, as he carefully reaches back and pierces his ear. I'm surprised he's able to do it so easily without showing any pain, but then I realize that Cassiel already numbed his ear for him with her magic. "I'm surprised you thought of something like this. Heck, this is more advanced than anything I've ever seen before. These communication crystals defy the laws of physics."

Cassiel winces as she sticks the little gem in her earlobe, but after a moment, her pain subsides. "They're pretty, too. I bet the crystal takes ten years off my figure." I decide not to cynically remark that ten years out of a hundred million isn't a big dent. I'd prefer not to end up in the doghouse.

Samantha follows through and even shudders a little as the pin goes in. I detect an alarming amount of blood rushing to her face as her face contorts into an expression of ecstasy. *Ah yes, I forgot she was a sadist and a masochist at the same time.* "This is great, love. You should give us presents more often!"

"I should," I say, nodding along with her words. "Anyway, Ben, give one of these to each of the guards on patrol and have them swap the earrings out whenever they go off duty. I'll make more of them later."

Ben raises an eyebrow. "These pierce the ear, Jason. That's a great way to mix blood together and start an infectious disease. Why not make them clip onto the ears painlessly?"

"I considered that. The thing is, if I can cure Kolpox, I can cure any disease, so it's not that big of a deal. Beyond that, my quick test showed that the signal strengthened, as did the telepathic connection, but only if the earring connected somehow with the body's internal organs. It uses a human's weak spiritual energy to transmit the information greater distances, and with higher clarity. Without that, you'd have to hang out near relays to use the gems, and that would make them worthless."

Ben nods. "Makes sense. Well, do what you gotta do, but I'm looking forward to a more reliable method of communication. If a demon attacks again, I need something anyone can use. What if the demon guts the poor sap wearing one of these earrings?"

My teeth grit reflexively. "If that happens, the last thing he'll think of will be a loud cry for help. Before his body slumps over, one of the girls or me can show up and heal him, hopefully." I pause for a moment and glance up at the speck in the sky. "Oh, also, I forgot to mention... that satellite has an incinerator beam installed. If the need arises, I can vaporize any intruder in an instant. If the worst happens, I can have it destroy the whole planet."

Cassiel's eyes widen. "What do you mean? Why would you want something like that hanging over our heads?"

"I don't Cass. But, if the thing I saw inside of Ben were ever to spread, I might not be able to contain it. The satellite's just a fail-safe. Anyway, only the four of us know about it, and I'm not worried about demons or the primitive humans here figuring out how to hack its systems and turn it against us. We should be golden. Besides, this world is in its own dimension. You can only get here through the conduits I've provided."

"If you say so," Ben grumbles under his breath. "Anyway, I'll give these crystals to the relevant soldiers and scouts. Thanks for the assistance, Jason."

"I do what I can," I say, nodding politely. Ben stomps away, flattening the grass under his feet, but the light breeze causes the blades to rise up again after he's out of sight.

Samantha and Cassiel both are more reserved than usual, and Samantha keeps twiddling the earring absentmindedly glancing at me, then back to Cass. "Why didn't you do the satellite thing sooner?"

I shrug. "It didn't occur to me. I thought about it after the attack yesterday, and remembered that one I made over Earth when I was looking for Marie's facility. It occurred to me that I should try relying on technology a bit more often since it doesn't have the weaknesses I do."

After a moment, I tap on my lip. "You know, that Hypersuit of Ben's is very convenient. It's made me realize that I haven't been cautious enough against the demons, or inventive enough, for that matter."

As I turn and start walking toward the town, Sam grabs my right arm, and Cassiel grabs my left, and both of them fall into step beside me. "What do you mean by that, love? Are you going to create some hideous new weapon?"

"Oh, definitely not. I think a planet-vaporizer in the sky is enough of that for one day. Still, I'm thinking about making a watch that can detect nearby hostiles, or perhaps a mind scrambler that only works on demons. Incapacitation would be the best way of dealing with them, but I don't want them being knocked out, then killed by humans while they're defenseless. That will send the wrong message."

A look of pain sprouts on Samantha's face as we walk through the gate at the front of the palace. The female guard nods politely at us, and Cassiel returns the gesture, but Samantha doesn't even notice her. "The violence between humans and demons should be solvable. If Diablo weren't such a thick-headed idiot, I'm sure we could work something out."

"We won't know until we try," I say, as we start to stroll down the street together.

Several minutes pass, and we arrive in the marketplace once again. Just for kicks, I Wordsmith " **Watch.** " to create a wrist-gizmo that allows me to create a holographic display that hovers above my arm, displaying nearby demons as red dots, and nearby humans as blue ones. Cassiel keeps waving her hand through the hologram to poke at the dots, but I haven't built any touch functionality into it yet, so nothing happens.

Cassiel puffs her lower lip out. "You know, you could make some goggles that would do the identifying for you. They'd stand out less than that watch does, and it might even look stylish."

Samantha seems to like the idea. "I say go for green. Green would look better on you than glasses or sunglasses."

From down the street, a little boy yells out and tugs at his mother's long turquoise skirt. "Mum, look! It's the Divine Mother! She's back!"

To my surprise, Cassiel smiles at the little boy and pulls away from me to walk over and kneel down to his level. "Alex! How are you doing?"

I glance at Samantha. "She knows him?"

Sam just shrugs. "I guess so."

The boy nods excitedly and babbles at Cassiel for a minute or two, asking her about 'that big robot of yours' and even about the duck. Why do people care about Howard so much? I know birds are a scarcity on this planet, but still.

Another minute passes, and Samantha starts tapping her foot impatiently. I'm starting to feel the same way until the boy's enthusiasm dissipates. "Did you find Susie?"

Cass's smile fades. "Ah, not yet. I'm sure she's fine, though."

"Oh. Okay. Well, you're the Divine Mother, so if you pinkie promise me that you'll find her, I won't worry!" Alex thrusts his pinkie forward and nods enthusiastically. It's at this moment that I remember when Cassiel and I were visiting that church a few days ago.

Their bodies were maimed, their throats scorched. They couldn't even cry for help as the killer tore them to pieces. What we recovered was barely a corpse.

A demon, or several of them, have to be the culprit. That's why the satellite is essential. It will record a view of the world, continuously, allowing me to find out who this mystery killer is. There haven't been any more murders for over a week now, but they could strike again.

A burned throat... all the victims are human... and to top it off, only one demon has left the city since the murders happened. It's too convenient.

Ah! That's right! I was going to track Beelzebub down before those shadow-walkers struck! Curse my shitty memory.

" **Locate.** " I speak the word aloud, and Samantha jerks her head up to look at me questioningly.

"Why are you Wordsmithing all of a sudden? Something on your mind?"

My magical vision stretches out, just as the Hand of God would, sweeping across the vast, unlimited cosmos, in search of my prey. Like an infinite number of spiritual birds of prey, I scan every nook and cranny of the universe, until I find my target.

Beelzebub.

Err, what? That doesn't make sense. He's right outside the second entrance? Not even a half-mile from it. Why would he be *there*?

A voice speaks, in my mind, faint at first, but it quickly clears up and reveals its owner to be Benjamin Brown.

Jason! Jason! Is this thing working? Hello?

Ah, he must be trying to use the new earrings I just gave him. It's a good idea to test them and make sure they work.

Yeah, I'm here. It's an open frequency, so Samantha and Cassiel, as well as anyone else you gave an earring to can hear you. What's up?

Ben's mental voice is strained. *The demons are here again. A whole horde of them. I need you to come to me, right now.*

My heart sinks. *I'll grab the girls and meet you at the second entrance.*

Ben responds with confusion. *Huh? No, the horde is at the Great Doors! The main entrance to the city! We haven't had time to set up defenses yet. At least ten thousand orcs and skeletons, all of them bunched together and looking for trouble. Get over here as quickly as possible.*

Beelzebub is at the second entrance. Maybe I misunderstood the situation, and he's just returning to the city for some other reason. I'll visit him after I'm done with this random horde of monsters.

I turn my attention back to reality just as Cassiel walks over to me. "I heard everything. Let's go."

Aiming my mind at both of them and myself, I use word magic to send us over to Benjamin. **"Teleport. "**

...And immediately trip over something as I arrive, stumble forward, and slam into Ben, knocking him down as I fall on top of him. I quickly jump to my feet and wince apologetically. "Sorry. I didn't know you'd be right there. Luckily, my teleport never puts me inside of physical objects."

Ben scowls. "Yeah. Lucky." He hops up and points at the Great Doors, both of which are standing in midair, eerily looming over the city. "We've got a guy on the outside, a scout. He's scared shitless, but we can't open the doors to let him in, or those monsters will pour through." Ben pauses as his face contorts into an odd smile. "To be honest, with my Hypersuit, they probably wouldn't make it within ten feet of the door, but since you seem keen on avoiding

outright killing them, I thought I'd give you a chance to settle things the easy way. If you fail, I'll solve this problem the *really* easy way. All orcs must die, as the saying goes."

Good to see Ben's gung-ho, at least. "Did you give those earrings out already?"

"Not yet. Why do you ask?"

That feeling of uneasiness makes my stomach churn. "Do me a favor. Go to the second entrance and hand out the communication crystals to the scouts, then let me know what the situation is."

Ben raises an eyebrow. "I'm sure you can handle a horde by yourself, but you won't even let me watch? And here I thought we were friends."

"It's not like that. I just have this feeling that something big is about to happen. The demons are acting way too erratic lately. Sam and Cass both noticed the change too. How fast can you get to the second entrance?"

"Pretty quickly." Ben says, shrugging. "The Hypersuit can travel at speeds of up to Mach 4 without causing damage to the pilot, but the sonic boom will blow out windows all over the city. How soon do you need me to do this?"

"Keep it just under the speed of sound, but don't dawdle. Tell me what's going on as soon as you get there."

With a nod, Ben sets his teeth firmly. "I haven't had a good run in a while."

The words have hardly left his mouth before his helmet slams shut and he vanishes, the force of his exit velocity nearly knocks the girls and me off our feet.

After I gather my wits, I look at one of the nearby operators. "Activate the pulleys! Get those doors open."

A horrendous grinding sound activates as the man starts cranking the dial on his console up to maximum speed. The device I built to open the doors from this side, comprised of unbelievably strong metal ropes and steel beams, activates and pulls them apart, slowly revealing the dark Labyrinth inside. The instant the doors are barely a foot open, a single man rushes inside, tripping over himself to flee to safety. "Monsters! Demons! Hideous things!"

He runs past us, fleeing in terror for the things inside, and Samantha chuckles. "Well, orcs and skeletons *are* pretty devil-damned ugly."

I don't return the laugh. "Stay here. I'll see what's going on."

My boots crunch against the gravelly ground, shifting pebbles together under my shoe and apart from where the edges land. The moment I step through the doors, the brightness of the

sun above dims dramatically, allowing me to see the legion of monsters up ahead. As reported, ten thousand or so of them lurk in the darkness, though none make a move toward me. Why are they waiting?

A single orc steps forward, his green skin standing in sharp contrast to the blood-red rags draped all over his body, and two mean-looking jagged swords hanging at his sides.

"You! Small human! Me Glonk! Me here kill you, rape your women, kill your children, burn your city! Glonk take no prisoner! However, Glonk always ready for honor combat! You fight Glonk and win, he spare your city. If Glonk win, he leave nothing standing!"

Oh. This big one wants to fight me one on one? That's all?

"I'll pass. Is this the entire army you brought? How were you expecting to get inside? A hundred orcs wouldn't have the strength to open the Great Doors. Are you stupid?"

I realize a moment after asking that *I'm talking to orcs. Of course they're stupid.*

Glonk's eyes bulge from his head. "Glonk no stupid! Glonk smartest of orcs! You die for what you say!"

Samantha appears beside me from out of nowhere. Her eyes narrow. "He's not the smartest orc I've ever met, but his ego is right up there with the worst of them. Can this even be called an assault force?"

The orcs and skeletons start to charge down the hallway that I once used to flee from Gressil, and I shrug in response. "The horde is scary-looking, but weak compared to what humanity can manage. **PUSH!** "

With a terrific shout, a blast of energy surges from my body, races down the hallway, and smashes the throng backward with the force of ten hurricanes. Their bodies go flying, the skeletons are crushed under the weight of their massive peers, and the orcs vanish into the darkness. Just for good measure, I do it a second time. " **PUSH!** "

Several seconds pass, but no sounds emanate from where I sent them flying. "I hope I didn't kill them."

"I doubt that, but you probably showed them the futility of attacking. What now?"

I chuckle under my breath. " **Storage.** " I reach inside and pull out the crown of Solomon, then Wordsmith again. " **Turret. Turret.** "

On each side of the Great Doors, two absolutely stupendous mega-turrets appear, towering high into the sky. Their cannons form into Gatling guns, capable of firing 2,000 rounds per minute, with the one on the right firing anti-energy, and the one on the left firing tank-buster bullets.

Just for good measure, I cast another spell. " **Link.** "

Now if the turrets fire, they'll send an alert to my satellite, and it, in turn, will alert me when they detect enemies.

Samantha looks from one turret to the other and laughs. "Hey now, weren't we going to avoid any killing if possible?"

I nod but don't bother to answer her question. Looking down the corridor, I wordsmith again. " **Amplify.** "

Now to take a deep breath, and make sure they can hear me, all the way down the corridor.

"HEY! YOU STUPID FUCKING ORCS! IF YOU COME BACK FOR MORE, I'VE GOT CANNONS SET UP THAT WILL BLOW YOUR BODIES APART IN A VERY HORRIFIC PAINFUL DISPLAY OF VIOLENCE THAT'LL TRAUMATIZE YOU AND YOUR DESCENDANTS FOR GENERATIONS TO COME! IF YOU FUCK WITH ME, YOU WILL NOT WALK AWAY FROM OUR NEXT MEETING ALIVE!"

After I finish yelling, I glance at Samantha, and see a look of pain on her face as she covers her ears. "A little warning, next time."

"Sorry."

The silence is deafening. After a minute with no response, I turn to walk away, but the sound of pattering footsteps in the distance catches my ear. From the darkness, Glonk emerges, his shoulder dislocated, and his arm bent around behind his back, but he shows no signs of feeling pain.

"Glonk no afraid. Glonk make you pay for dishonor!"

And, right on cue, both cannons swivel to face him. I cup my hands over my ears, and they fire.

Ratatatatatatata!

A hail of bullets blasts Glonk apart from his head to his toe, hitting him with the pinpoint precision that only a machine could manage. His body is nearly vaporized by the tank-buster bullets blasting apart every atom of his being, and two seconds later, all that's left of him is a single sandal.

I smirk at Samantha. "Hey, I warned him. I can't be held responsible for that."

"Oh, you ass!" Sam says as she slugs me in the shoulder playfully.

I tap into the earpiece with my mind. *Ben, what's going on at the second entrance?*

No response.

Ben?

Finally, he answers me.

Jason, did you stop those orcs?

His mental tone worries me.

Yeah. Why?

Come to the second entrance. The orcs were just a diversion. The true battle is over here.

Part 468c: The Emperor Of Flames

"Look what the Hellhound dragged in," Beelzebub quips as I teleport to Ben's location. Cassiel and Samantha pop in beside me and shake the sensation of disorientation off in an instant. "I'm guessing the Orcs, Skeletons, and Vampires couldn't delay the *mighty* Wordsmith for as long as I'd hoped."

I shoot a glance at Samantha, then back to Beelzebub. "I only saw Skeletons and Orcs. But you're right; they didn't last long."

"Accursed vampires. Sloth is their greatest weakness. Can't even show up for a quick distraction."

My eyes flick to the side to look past Beelzebub, and I spot several species of monsters I haven't seen before, all of them lined up behind him, ready for action. Two massive golems, their bodies made of brick-shaped rocks, stand fifty feet tall, towering over all the smaller monster swarming around their feet. Aside from them, dozens of harpies, goblins, scythers, and other assorted monsters cluster together, waiting for Beelzebub to give the command to attack.

"You returned to the demon side, huh? I guess Diablo needs a new field commander after Samantha took him out of commission. What does turning coat pay nowadays?"

Beelzebub *tsks* at me, and Samantha nudges my arm. "Jason, Beelzebub is different. You probably can't sense it, but he has way more energy than he did before. A stupid increase, if I'm reading it correctly."

"Quite right, Belial. You may be a filthy human-lover, but you can sense the power of royalty when it presents itself." Beelzebub fans out his fingers to examine his nails, and puts on an amused smile. "I suppose you could call my new power a *gift* from Diablo. He couldn't give me his energy quickly enough."

"Nice one, boss!" A goblin cackles in the background, but Beelzebub doesn't think it's amusing.

"You'll speak when spoken to, worm." With a flick of his finger, a tremendous flame balls up in Beelzebub's hand, sucking the oxygen from the air in a single second, and he compresses the flame into a tiny water-drop sized ball, then fires it at the goblin.

The poor sap doesn't get a chance to contemplate his existence. The instant the fire strikes his chest, his body swells up like a balloon and explodes, showering the horde behind Beelzebub

in a gory fountain of blood. Whatever Beelzebub hit him with, it was condensed like a tiny atom-bomb.

"Gross," remarks a Harpy in the front row. She shakes the blood from her wings and scowls at Beelzebub, but a menacing glare from him shuts her up instantly.

"What was I saying before the peasant so *rudely* interrupted me? Ah, that's right, I remember." Beelzebub quickly pivots back to us and forces another fake smile. "I'm here to kill all of you, by order of the First Emperor. I should be polite and firstly inform you of the recent changes in demonic hierarchy, since you clearly weren't aware of my surge in power. I am the new Second Emperor of the demons, ousting the failed leader, Diablo, and now I even surpass the power of Belial, thanks to a most generous energy increase from our dear First Emperor."

Samantha is unamused. "You mean, Satan, right?"

Her simple reply makes a vein bulge on Beelzebub's forehead, though he tries not to let his sudden frustration shine through. "O-oh, you remember? He told me that he wiped your memory. Well, at least that makes things simpler, though he won't be pleased that the sphinx is out of the bag." Another look of irritation appears and he relents to scowl at me. "I assume you restored the whore's memories?"

"Yes, but don't call her a whore. I have a new no-killing policy, but even for a *good friend* like you, nothing's stopping me from reverting to my old ways."

"Always the white knight, I see. A hero trying to flee from his bloody, dictatorial past. Tell me, though, if you won't kill anyone, how will you defeat me in a battle?"

His question might usually inspire a long-winded answer, but this time I opt to show instead of tell. " **Sleep.** "

All at once, a series of sounds resembling boulders bouncing down a hill create music for my ears, as the horde behind Beelzebub suddenly trips over themselves and flop to the ground, fast asleep. Curiously, the two massive golems are unaffected. Probably a good thing, considering if they fell over, they'd crush the smaller ones beneath them.

Beelzebub yawns dramatically. "Oh yes, use your Wordsmithing to put them to sleep. Nobody saw that coming."

What happens next takes me aback. Beelzebub snaps his fingers, and the moment he clicks them, my spell is broken. All the monsters suddenly wake up and clamber back into a standing position, confusion on their faces.

It looks like Beelzebub learned some new abilities. "How did you do that?"

Cassiel, silent up to now, interjects before he can answer. "He couldn't possibly have used magic. Snapping a finger doesn't activate magic, at least not for demons."

"Are you sure about that?" Beelzebub chortles to himself. "I'm not the same demon I once was. Go on, try something new. You have two more chances, but if you won't kill or defeat us, I'll-"

He doesn't get to finish his sentence. From out of nowhere, Benjamin Brown leaps into action, blasting up to Beelzebub at nearly the speed of sound, and delivering a punch right to his face with an explosive level of power that knocks his head clean off. Ben follows up with a terrific blast of energy from the palm of his hand, obliterating Beelzebub's body instantly, and creating a massive impact crater on the ground.

Every monster leaps back in fright, except for the golems who stare forward blankly. Ben coughs into his fist. "Stupid fucker. I couldn't stand to hear him blather on for a moment longer. Why do you idiots always let the bad guy just sit there and talk? Take a weapon and blow his fucking head off! It's not rocket science!"

"You wound me."

From the horde of monsters, Beelzebub emerges out of nowhere and strides over to us. He nods at Ben. "That was a good effort, black-skinned, white-armored man with the unkempt beard. Fortunately, such profane and impolite violence will not work against the Emperor of Flames."

"What the fuck?!" Ben practically spits the words out. "I took your head clean off! No demon magic I've ever seen can prevent death!"

A moment passes, and Beelzebub stares at Ben blankly. Then, he chuckles. "Perhaps. Of course, I've died once before, so I probably know more on the subject than you."

Ben grits his teeth. "The fuck you do." His eyes swing over to me. "He's a clone. That ain't the real Beelzebub. Neither was the first one I killed."

Beelzebub's smile vanishes. " *What?* How could you have figured that out so quickly?"

"Oh, simple. I'm a clone of the original Benjamin Brown. It's something that keeps me awake at night; I'm sure you understand. Jason, look for the original. I need to break his back and shove an apple in his mouth."

I don't know how Ben pieced together this information so quickly, but my warning bells are going off. "How can you clone yourself? You've never had magic like that. And waking up the monsters- that's not something you can do."

Casually, Beelzebub begins to pace back and forth. "Fire brings death and destruction, but it also brings life. After you killed me, those few years ago, my revival taught me that death could be defied. I've plotted, brainstormed, and calculated all the ways your Wordsmithing worked, and finally ended up with ways to counter it."

Despite his short speech, neither the girls nor I believe him. Cassiel smiles uneasily. "If you keep lying like that, your *pants* will be the new Emperor of Flames. Don't tell me you killed the people in Hero City just to experiment with cloning."

"I've done what I needed to increase my powers," Beelzebub says, as his tone becomes defensive. "I didn't kill any humans, though. Not that I wouldn't want to, of course. In fact..."

The words leave Beelzebub's mouth, and a flame suddenly sprouts in his hand.

"Look out!" Ben's helmet closes up, and he races forward, just as Beelzebub hurls the micro-bomb of fire at our soldiers in the rear flanks.

The pinpoint of flame explodes against Ben's armor, sending him flying backward, where he smashes into half a dozen men and women, and the blast surges outward, nearly engulfing the girls and I in it. Before that can happen, Cassiel raises her hand and a barrier of light shields us from the worst of it.

We don't get a second to catch our breath. Five more balls of fire appear above each of Beelzebub's fingers, but just as he's about to throw them, I yell, " **Extinguish!** "

The fireballs vanish, but reappear an instant later, and he sends the bombs toward our flanks, fanning them out in several directions at once.

I can't say the words in time! He's going to-!

The flames suddenly vanish in mid-air, and I realize with a start that Ionis has appeared in front of the soldiers. He cradles Howard in both arms, and the duck stares at me, almost judgmentally.

ORGANIC UNIT DESIGNATED JASON HIRO; THE COMMANDER UNIT HAS ORDERED ME TO PROTECT THE ANGEL-TYPE ORGANIC AT ALL COSTS.

Beelzebub jerks back in surprise. "The robot? Where- how?! My flames!"

I breathe a sigh of relief, though that was way too close of a call. "N-nice work, Ionis. I don't think Cassiel needs any saving, but those men did."

A few moments pass, and my heart pounds in my chest. *I've had enough of this shit.*

I'm still wearing the Crown of Solomon. Time to put it to use.

" **Teleport! Bomb!** "

With two words, I forcibly send Samantha and Cassiel to the rear flanks, several dozen feet away, and a strange, perfectly round sphere of metal appears in my hand.

"Beelzebub, I didn't want to kill anyone today, including you, but I've just changed my mind. The next time you make the wrong move, I'll detonate this."

He doesn't flinch. "Oh no, a bomb. Yes, kill us all, including your comrades, why don't you? Even you wouldn't be that foolish."

"This isn't an ordinary bomb. It's a magical device. I've designed it to teleport all nearby angels and humans back to Hero City the instant it detonates. However, all demons in the immediate radius will be engulfed in a deadly radiation that will melt their body, killing them instantly. This includes Samantha, but I'll teleport her to safety before that can happen."

Beelzebub's smirk vanishes, and I eye him carefully. "Go ahead, Beelzy. Try me. Make my day. It won't be my fault if you die."

He takes two steps back and evaluates the device in my hand carefully. "You're bluffing. Either that, or the human has finally remembered his savage roots."

"Yeah, I'm a savage, all right. Let me guess; the real Beelzebub is hidden away somewhere safe, and if you die, he'll just create another one. The thing is, you care a lot about your image. Even if you dying won't bother him, losing all those monsters will make you look like a shitty leader to the rest of the demons. It'll be a loss, and you *hate* losing. Sound about right?"

He slowly licks his lips. "When did you have the time to give my personality so much thought? You can't be the Jason I know."

I shrug. "I'm trying to improve myself. What can I say?"

Beelzebub doesn't find my reply amusing. "There's something you didn't think of, though. What if there aren't any monsters to kill?"

Again, Beelzebub snaps his fingers, and instantly the golems, harpies, goblins, and every other creature vanish. They simply pop out of existence.

Just as if I had teleported them with my Wordsmithing.

Beelzebub ignites a flame above his finger and points it at my bomb. "There's nothing more fun than calling a bluff."

He releases the fire.

Part 469c: Unexpected Guests

Beelzebub's smile widens maniacally as he lobs the compressed ball of flaming death and shoots it two feet forward to my bomb. I don't have time to think! I have to get Samantha out of here!

" **Tele-** "

Before I can finish, it's already too late. The fireball strikes the metal sphere and...

...Nothing happens.

Beelzebub's smile slips. " *What?* "

I quickly jump back as Beelzebub stares at me in silence. " **Storage.** " A void appears, and I toss my bomb inside, then seal it up afterward. That was close.

"You were bluffing. The bomb didn't explode," Beelzebub says, as his face returns to a neutral resting position. "...Yet you hide it in your storage. What are you trying to pull?"

My breathing quickens as he raises his hands up, and this time five balls of fire appear, each hovering above one of his fingers. "The bomb should have exploded. I thought you stopped the fire before it hit. Are you saying I did something?"

He clenches his teeth and flings the fireballs in a spread pattern, one at me, the rest toward the wall of people in the rear. "Humans always lie!"

Cassiel quickly raises a hand and forms a magical barrier around the soldiers, Samantha, and herself, but just before the fireballs hit, they suddenly vanish, as if someone had snuffed out the wick of a candle.

"What the devils? How are you doing that?!" Beelzebub sputters angrily, but my heart stops as something appears behind him. A demon, standing as tall as the golems were just a minute before, his black skin blending in with the darkness around him, his eyes red like the fires of Hell. The colossal monster rumbles in his throat and the walls shake around us.

" **Beelzebub, I ordered you to kill the Wordsmith. Instead, you endangered Belial's life with your foolishness.** "

Beelzebub freezes, before whipping his head around to stare at a leg that dwarfs him in size. "A-ah, First Emperor! I didn't- that is, I wasn't going to do anything that would anger you!"

First Emperor? This guy is Satan? But he's huge! The Satan I fought when Amelia summoned him was only a little taller than I am now. This monster can't possibly be him!

Samantha and Cassiel walk and fly, respectively, to my side. Samantha's posture shows a small amount of anxiety, but Cassiel's eyes hold a silent rage. "Hey! Satan! What's with that giant body?! Are you trying to over-compensate for something?!"

Satan, if that's who the behemoth is, ignores Cassiel. " **Beelzebub, you heard the Wordsmith. The bomb would have killed all demons in its radius, including Belial. Why did you take such a risk, knowing my reaction?** "

Beelzebub takes a step back. "I apologize, master. It won't happen again."

" **Good. Now do as I ordered, and kill the Wordsmith. If you can't kill an unevolved Jason, you'll be worthless to me.** "

What the hell does he mean by that? An unevolved Jason? No, more importantly, doesn't this indicate that Samantha was right? She told me that there might be other Jasons out there.

I steal a glance at her, and she nods. "It's as I thought. Satan is toying with you."

Bastard. Does he think war is a game? Lives are on the line, and he casually chit-chats at a time like this? To my surprise, the giant demon heaves a sigh, then begins to shrink. His skin changes from black to red, and a familiar figure replaces the unsightly one. This time, I recognize him as Satan immediately.

"I'm not toying with him, Lilia. Since you remember who I am, he must have restored your other memories as well. Jason is a danger to everything demonkind stands for. As you should now remember, he isn't the only Wordsmith out there. Killing him is the only way to protect the future of your people."

"Stuff it, blabber-mouth," Cassiel says, as she slowly pulls Samantha behind her. "You're sick. Sammy told me all about you- all about what you did to her. I've got half a mind to tear you apart right now, and I have a rule about not attacking people. As far as I'm concerned, you're just a dog that needs to be put down."

Satan ignored her once already, but this time smoke flows from his nostrils. "Jason, keep that wench of yours at bay. I don't like to hurt women, but when they get mouthy, I won't hesitate to put them in their place."

"Hey! Are you threatening Cass?" Samantha balks at the First Emperor of the demons. "What's wrong with you? When did you become so hateful?!"

The tension builds, as Satan's eyes lock onto Sam's. "I've always been bitter. Perhaps your shoddy memory has turned you senile, Lilia, but at one point I recall you sharing my convictions regarding angels. The fact I'm allowing the winged bitch to speak at all, rather than killing her now, is proof that I've softened. Then there's the matter of your infidelity, even after I

revealed myself to you. I know that you secretly loathe the human, yet you fail to plunge the metaphorical dagger in his back and return to my side. Why? Have I not treated you well? I gave you free range of the Labyrinth, gave you the power to do as you pleased, yet you continue to stand beside... *him*. What have I done to deserve such a thankless mate?"

I pause to take the situation in, and the scope doesn't escape me. A Wordsmith, an angel, and a demon, against the leader of the demons and a prick with a hard-on for power, all of us standing here having a chat about Satan's relationship problems. If the threat of imminent death weren't hanging over my head, I'd laugh.

Satan's dark energy is like a poisonous gas. Miasma stretches out from his body, unseen, and suffocates my energy with its grip. While he pleads with Belial, goads her, or whatever the hell he's doing, a realization that he doesn't think of me as a threat holds me back from making a move. If he's that confident and powerful, I don't see how I can win a battle against him.

Samantha's lip quivers. "I didn't ask for those things. When I was young and foolish, I sought power, but I quickly tired of it. I gave up that life long ago. The only reason I never gave my energy to another demon was that I thought of myself as the most level-headed of our kind. Perhaps I've only just realized, but you continue to seek revenge, not caring about the toll it exacts upon your brethren." She rests her hand on Cassiel's shoulder. "Demons languish in stagnation because you chose to hide in the shadows instead of leading us to a better future. Rather than killing and subjugating humans, we should seek to live among them peacefully, as I do with Jason and Cassiel. Forget the old rivalries! Get rid of your anger, and accept our differences! We don't have to fight, backstab, and kill our way to domination!"

The anger fades from Satan's eyes, and a soft look replaces it. "Lilia... do you really think like that? You believe I can simply ignore the past?"

She nods. "I do."

"Ah." Satan whispers the word and slowly turns to look at Beelzebub. "And what of you? Do you agree with her beliefs?"

Beelzebub doesn't hesitate. "Of course not. Even if *you* could forget the past, I hate humans for being pathetic, worthless creatures. I despise them for what they are *now*, not because of some ancient, petty rivalry."

A moment passes. Satan chuckles. "Heh. You're right, Beelzebub. The Lilia I know would never say such wretched words. Calculated thoughts are not the way a succubus thinks." He pauses, and his eyes glow red as he looks at me, then to Cassiel. "It's your influence. You changed Lilia. You took her from me, brainwashed her, warped her thoughts. Your ideals have poisoned her mind."

"Stop acting like I can't have opinions, Satan. I'm not a puppet with strings you can pull to make me dance!" Tears well up in Samantha's eyes, and suddenly she lunges forward, and punches Satan in the chest with such force that the shockwave makes Cassiel, Beelzebub and I all stumble back in surprise. "Asshole! I can't believe you! I can't believe I ever had feelings for you! Am I nothing but meat in the shape of a woman to you?!"

Her attack doesn't faze Satan. In fact, he doesn't appear to feel it. "A puppet, you say? Interesting. I hadn't considered that possibility."

A flash of movement. Satan's hand darts out and slaps Belial with unbelievable force, sending her sailing past Cassiel and I and smashing into a wall to our right side. Samantha flops forward and passes out, as her body lands in an unnatural position.

"Sammy!" Cassiel shrieks in surprise and starts to run to her side. Before she can take two steps, Satan glares at her.

"Filthy angel." The moment the words leave his mouth, Cassiel shrieks in pain, as both of her wings are torn from her body, ripped off by something unseen. She trips forward and nearly hits the ground, but I quickly jump over and catch her.

" **Heal! HEAL!!** " I use my wordsmithing, but the wounds won't close. Blood pours from the spots where her wings were ripped out, and bones jut forth, like icicles made of bone. I can't heal Samantha either! Her right arm hangs behind her back, dislocated.

Rage builds up inside of me. "Satan! Stop nullifying my Wordsmithing! Bastard! How can you hurt the woman you love like that?!"

He laughs. "Haha, don't tell me you're having trouble keeping up? What's the matter, is the speed of your mouth too slow to beat the speed of thought? Lilia is counting on you to be her savior, but you pale in comparison to my-"

Before he can finish, an angry squawking fills the room, and Howard lunges out of Ionis's arms, and flies over to Satan, smacking into his face and *warking* repeatedly as he pecks the Devil over and over.

"Gah! Get this- get off me!" Satan loses his cool and reaches out with his hand, delivering a single slap at the angry bird. A sickening *crunch* fills the room, and Howard blasts into the ground with the force of a meteor, breaking all of his bones and killing him instantly.

Without a doubt, he's dead. I stare in stunned silence, and Cassiel even manages to stop moaning in pain to gaze at his body. "H-Howard! You- you goddamned-!"

Satan grimaces. "Stupid animal! Was that your final weapon, Wordsmith?! You can't use your precious magic, so you pelt me with annoyances, hoping I'll slip up? Beelzebub! Kill him!"

He can't defend himself anymore! He's practically-"

A humming fills the room, interrupting the leader of the demons and cutting him off mid-sentence. The walls vibrate, and stones shift around on the ground. Howard's broken body trembles as the area around him reverberates fiercely.

Inside my head, a familiar voice appears; one I've heard dozens of times over the last few months but grown annoyed whenever it speaks.

HYPER-INTELLIGENT COMMANDER UNIT DESIGNATED 'HOWARD' HAS BEEN DISASSEMBLED. WARNING; WITHOUT A COMMANDER UNIT TO LEAD THIS SENTINEL, RELEVANT MISSION DATA HAS BEEN COMPROMISED. RESTORING PRIMARY FUNCTIONALITY. OBJECTIVE; REBUILD THE SENTINELS. OBJECTIVE RESTORED. OBJECTIVE; ELIMINATE ALL THREATS. OBJECTIVE RESTORED. QUANTIFYING THREATS NOW.

A look of trepidation appears on Satan's face. "That... that voice... who is that?"

Beelzebub glances around, and his eyes lock onto Ionis, standing in front of the small legion of soldiers who silently watch everything happening around them. "The voice was robotic. It might be... the big thing over there."

As if noticing Ionis for the first time, Satan's face pales. "No... no no no... Beelzebub, that thing looks an awful lot like a Sen-"

Instantly, all the humans behind Ionis gasp, before stumbling forward and falling over. Their bodies flop apart, cut in half right across the stomach.

MINOR THREATS PURGED. MAJOR THREATS QUANTIFIED. ALL ORGANICS ARE THE ENEMY OF THE SENTINELS. ALL ORGANICS WILL BE DISASSEMBLED.

For a brief second, I see what looks almost like a laser, but I don't have time to understand if that's correct, because Beelzebub screams in pain, then falls to the ground, his body cut in half as well.

The ground beside Satan blasts apart as if a tiny meteorite had just hit it. Satan holds his hand up at the robot and takes a step back. "Easy now, Sentinel. I know what you're capable of, BUT you won't be able to beat me like you did those clones. Don't do anything foolish, you mangy hunk of bolts."

Ionis's eye lights up, and a massive blast of energy shoots at Satan, but ricochets off an invisible force field in front of him, then blasts up into the ceiling, knocking chunks of rock apart and raining down on us.

A voice whispers in my ear, and I realize it's Ben's voice. "Keep quiet. We gotta get out of here. There's no use fighting a Sentinel." He sounds urgent, but I can't see him at all, then I remember his suit can turn invisible.

With Satan's attention firmly on Ionis, I wordsmith quickly. " **Heal. Heal.** " This time, I'm elated to see the wounds on Cassiel's back close up, and Samantha's arm shifts back into place. Even though she moans in pain, she stays unconscious.

THE ORGANIC DEMON-TYPE KNOWN AS 'SATAN' IS RESPONSIBLE FOR THE DISASSEMBLY OF THE COMMANDER UNIT. THIS SENTINEL UNIT WILL DISASSEMBLE THE DEMON-TYPE ORGANIC.

Ionis jumps at Satan, and the leader of the demons jumps back in fright. "No! No disassemble! Down, boy! Nice robot!"

Cassiel whimpers in my arms, and her breath comes in ragged gasps. "M-my energy... I don't have... any energy... he took it..."

Ben's invisible form lifts up Samantha's body, but he pauses for a moment, though I can't see what he's doing. "Get us back to Hero City. Then, seal all the portals."

"Right. **Telep-** "

For the fiftieth time today, something interrupts me mid-cast, but I'm stunned to see a new portal open in the distance, and a blast of light passes through it. As Ionis blast's Satan's weakening shield with lasers, an old man steps through the portal, followed by a woman with wings. An *angel*, to be precise.

"What in tarnation is goin' on?! Helen! I told ya! It's a Sentinel!"

The old man looks to be about eighty, with droopy skin and grey hair all over his body, yet he also seems *plastic*, as if he isn't human at all. Despite his age, he strikes a posture that one would be hard-pressed to call 'weak'.

The angel, apparently named Helen, ducks down behind him. "Send the signal already, Harold! Look who it's fighting!"

Ionis delivers a devastating punch to Satan's barrier, and visible cracks form in the air. Satan breathes heavily, and pants as the unstoppable killing machine hammers him, but he can't pause for even a second to wipe the sweat from his brow. Just when it looks like Satan's shield is about to shatter, Ionis's body vibrates and turns invisible, in the same way that Benjamin's Hypersuit would.

THREAT LEVEL INCREASED. ORGANIC DEMON-TYPE IS RESISTANT TO PRIMARY ATTACKS. INITIATING STEALTH MODE.

Satan's hands tremble, even as he forces a weak smile. "Stealth... mode...?"

A staggering laser blast from the back sends Satan flying forward, landing face-first in the corpses of the humans Ionis just killed. A faint shimmer, barely visible to the human eye, reveals Ionis's form a split-second before he lunges at Satan again, grabs him by the back of the head, and starts bashing his face in the ground.

Harold gawks at the ferocity. "Sumbitch, it's the doomsday protocol: a Sentinel and a Satan." He lifts his arm, and the skin on it pops up like the hatch on a submarine to reveal wiring and circuitry underneath. *He's a robot?!*

After poking two buttons quickly, Harold glances over and spots me. "Oh! Jason, you're already here! You shoulda told us before you-!"

"No, Harold, that one's much too young. Look at his skin! He has those odd tattoos, too."

I quickly pour some energy into Cassiel and glance over at Satan, just in time to see him vanish from Ionis's grasp.

"Oh, ding-damn, yer right! If he ain't Alpha, then he's proolly..." Harold trails off, then squints at me. His eyes shift oddly, and I realize he's using robotic vision augments to telescopically examine my face. "Hey, kid! What's your identifier!"

"Huh? Identifier?" I have no idea what he's talking about.

Satan reappears a few dozen feet away and quickly aims his hand at the spot where he thinks Ionis is standing. A blast of ice shoots out and fills the room in front of him, and to my surprise, he manages to catch Ionis and freeze the robot in place.

"Devil-damned metal monsters." Satan's face, though battered, heals up instantly without him making any signs. He glances over at the angel and the robot. "Now who the blazes are you?!"

The ice around Ionis begins to crack as the robot vibrates to generate heat, and Helen narrows her eyes. "Where is Alpha? Something's not right here. Satan should recognize you instantly, as should that Jason. They might be variants."

The moment Ionis breaks free, a figure suddenly appears right beside Harold. I do a double-take and gawk, once I realize I'm looking at a somewhat older version of myself, but with my pre-god-transformation skin color. His body glows yellow, and his eyes dart around the room as he quickly takes in the situation. "I was chasing down a clone in B13. What happened?" The words have hardly left his mouth before he notices Satan, Ionis charging at Satan, and myself.

"Oh. Good job, Harold. You made the right call."

"Give 'em hell, kid."

Part 470c:

"Give 'em hell, kid," Harold says, winking at me.

I quickly inhale and examine the situation. Another Satan clone, battling a Sentinel, check. A clone of me, check. A Cassiel variant, and Samantha as well... check. Oh look, Beelzebub's even writhing around on the ground, crying about his body being cut in half. Poor guy.

The Sentinel breaks out of the ice prison Satan had encapsulated it in, and jumps at the Emperor of Demons, savagely attacking him, though Satan is quickly getting better at defending himself. Something isn't right, though.

"Harold, that Sentinel is moving much slower than I remember. What's going on with it?"

The old man shrugs. "Ah, don'tcha know? We had that theory thingamabob that they cluster their data together 'n whatnot. Without other Sentinels in range, the thing's gonna be a lot slower."

"Oh. I forgot, thanks."

Harold is invaluable to me. Thanks to his cybernetic brain, he's capable of storing and retrieving a large amount of information instantly. He sounds like a country hick, but he's probably the smartest person on the crew, especially now that he's always connected to the backup servers thanks to the temporal signal override. "What about that Jason over there? He looks different. No, wait, not different... distinctive."

Satan howls in anger and grabs the Sentinel by the leg and starts thrashing it around the place, bashing it into the floor and against the walls, but he's no threat to me, so I just ignore him. Hell, the Sentinel's keeping the demon distracted for a moment so I can collect my bearings. Saves me the trouble.

Ah... now I remember. That black skin, those glowing tattoos... come to think of it, long ago, before I ever time traveled, I... yeah. Yeah, I remember now. This situation is memorable, as if I've lived it before.

"Harold, what universe are we in?"

The old man raises an eyebrow. "The one where we met. Your Source universe."

"What? The Source universe? That can't be right. We determined I was the Source. Who the hell is that Jason?"

"I wonder," Harold says, keeping his face blank. "I 'member a certain cryopod goin' missin' right after you tussled with Satan."

"No way- that's...!" I can almost see dots connecting in my mind, but then more questions come to mind. "We've never encountered two Satan clones at the same time, ever. What are the odds this mystery Jason and a second Satan would show up in the same place at the same time?"

"A few trillion ta' one, kid."

Helen slips forward. "I'm going to go help them. Those girls are in bad shape."

She doesn't wait for permission, and instead flutters over to the three odd-ones-out, even as my Hypersuit detects an invisible form lying in wait. Another Hypersuit?

"Helen, wait! There's someone over there!" I quickly aim my mind at the figure. *Reveal.*

His anti-energy field is too weak to handle my immense energy, and it overloads, making a popping noise. I breathe a sigh of relief as Benjamin Brown's face appears. He's one of the good guys. Hell, he's an agent in several dozen other universes. Funny thing about the multiverse- turns out some people never change.

Ben jerks his head around in surprise, but his guard drops when Helen smiles at him. "Oh, Benjamin, how are you, dear? Haven't had a good chat with one of you for quite a long time, sweetie."

He's confused, but I turn my attention back to Satan. He's growing more and more pissed at his inability to even dent the Sentinel, and just when he thinks he's made it past the armor, the Sentinel blasts him with a microscopic laser, severing his arm. Satan grows a new one back almost instantly, confirming he can also thoughtsmith.

Damn. Every Satan I kill takes something new out of me. They get craftier and trickier all the time, and just when I think I've killed the last one, another pops up. Sometimes I wonder if they're just toying with me to learn the extent of my abilities. Too bad that each new fight forces me to learn from the previous one, so they're only making me stronger.

"Harold, do you have those experimental shutdown switches available? I need to take that Sentinel down before it becomes a threat. Now's the perfect time to run a test."

The old man sighs. "Shucks, always tellin' me what ta' do... mumble grumble..." He reaches under his T-shirt, one with a pineapple on it that says 'I went to Hawaii and survived the Black Plague'. *Yeah yeah that wasn't my finest moment, but you don't have to mock me for it constantly.* Harold's chest pops open, and he pulls out the device, which looks something like an antenna with blue electricity contained in several tubes that coil around it, and one incredibly thin needle meant for stabbing things. Naturally, the needle is reinforced by my thoughtsmithing, so it's stronger than just about any compound in the universe.

Strong enough, even, to pierce the armor of a Sentinel. Hopefully. I haven't had a chance to try it out, but strike while the iron is hot, as they say.

All the while, Satan and the Sentinel take turns beating the shit out of each other, yet never making any progress, so I begin to enhance myself.

Speed. Speed. Speed. Power. Power. Power.

My right arm bulges as the muscles coil and flex, sometimes breaking nerves and other things, but I just repair the damage and keep focusing my energy.

I need a lot of stabbing power to pierce the hide of that thing, more than I've ever used before. I could hit the Sentinel with enough force to rip the Labyrinth in two, and it still might not be enough. I'd rather not face Sentinels again anytime soon, that's for sure.

Ah, that's about it. Any more strength and my arm is going to explode. This containment device is liable to shatter in my grip if I squeeze harder, so it's now or never.

I teleport over to the two fighting and sigh at the metal fist frozen in mid-air, ready to pound Satan's face in. Why didn't Satan recognize me when I showed up? All he ever does is taunt me over and over until I kill him, then he pops up in another stream, pulling my attention away. Is this what he's been reduced to, a troll under a bridge? I expected better from him.

My left hand lunges forward, grabs the Sentinel by the base of the neck, and pulls it back. Kneeling down, I lean the frozen robot's chest over my knee and hold my arm up in the air. My knee is going to hurt like never before once this is over. Yup, I'm probably going to shatter the damn thing.

Like a hammer of God, my hand drives the needle down with the force of a nuclear bomb, smashing the tip into the Sentinel's back. An instant passes, and I smile as the needle pierces the armor. It worked!

Then the shockwave hits me. The impact is that of a hurricane hitting every inch of my being all at once. My concentration is disrupted and time returns to normal, sending me hurtling backward, smashing into the wall at the far end of the room.

I'm fine, of course, but my head spins for a moment before my knee screams in agony. Yup, it's shattered- *holy fucking shit* that hurts! Oh my-! I think my goddamn leg exploded!

I crane my neck down and gasp at the condition of my leg. It's transformed from a limb into an appendage held together by strips of skin and a fragment of bone. *Heal! Regenerate!*

A sigh washes over me as the leg repairs, and once the healing finishes, I hop down from the wall. The leg works great! I've regenerated thousands of limbs, so it might as well be like

sharpening a pencil at this point. *Oooooh*, Satan doesn't look too good. He's also compressed against the opposite wall, though he's more stunned than injured.

"Wha- who-...?"

He mumbles something unintelligible, and I turn to the Sentinel. The single iris, usually red, is blue now. I put it in an inert state! Hallelujah, it worked!

I turn to give the thumbs up to Harold, only to realize he's leaning against the wall and his left arm is missing. The robotic appendage lies on the ground a few feet away, and the old man grumbles under his breath, cursing everything for which I stand. *Oops, uh, sorry, Harold.*

The other people aren't doing too great, either. My clone-person, or whoever he may be, lies crumpled in a heap along with Cassiel and Samantha. Helen dusts herself off and glares at me politely, in a way only she could manage. "Now now, perhaps next time you might offer a bit of warning? I scarcely got the barrier erected in time."

"Uh, hehe?" I can only offer the sweet old lady a nervous chuckle before turning back to Satan. He's the real 'threat' here, even if he's not exactly... a threat.

"Yo, Satan! I got called away from beating you up just to pop in and beat you up some more! What's going on, man? You doin' okay?" I teleport over to him and hoist him up to his feet, dusting him off quickly. "I mean, you probably won't be doing too good once I kill you again, haha."

He shakes the cloudiness from his eyes and becomes alert, then quickly shoves me back. "Devil-damn-it. You must be Jason Alpha. I've heard a lot about you."

My smile weakens. "Uh, yeah? What do you mean by that?"

Seconds pass. He glares at me, and I feel a sudden tightness in my throat. *Hold on... can it be? Every other Satan recognizes me and does the giggling, maniacal cackling thing... but this Satan is...*

"Are... are you the original? Are you the Seed?"

Satan's eyebrow raises. "Sadly, yes. It seems that all those years ago, I was right. I escaped death, and I've been executing my plan to eventually defeat you, once and for all."

"Uh-huh." My tongue snakes out, and I wet my lips. "You were hiding in the Source universe. Clever. Right in plain sight. How'd you do it? No- it doesn't matter. I've caught you, and once I kill you, I just have to keep hunting down all your fucking clones."

Satan forces a smile, but it's contrived. He doesn't have an out. "You sound confident. I've heard about how you brutally tear my clones to pieces but don't you find it odd? No matter how many you kill, more simply take their place. Even if you kill me, clones will make more clones."

Each and every one of them inherits my will. The best part is that we've allowed you to win, over and over again, so that you'd grow overconfident in your abilities."

"Yeah, *allowed*. Is there ever a moment where you don't lie?"

The First Emperor doesn't respond. For a few seconds, he stares into my eyes, until I feel that familiar sensation.

"Reading my thoughts? It's like that, huh?" I return the favor and start reading his mind in response.

His face twitches as he realizes what I'm doing, but he doesn't waver. *If you're so confident in your abilities human, take me down. Smite me with your divine powers.*

Yeah? Maybe I will. I telepathically send my thoughts to him, pulling a step closer. *I haven't forgotten what you did. It may have been millions of years, even tens of them, but far more time has passed from my point of view. I never forget. You took her from me. I loved Amelia, and you broke her mind. You will never escape.*

My goal is to win, not escape. Besides, you have time travel. If you loved the little cunt so much, just grab ten more from the other streams. This is why humans are so pathetic. You always get attached to your flings and think they matter.

There's a certain bitterness in his mental voice. A pang of regret that he doesn't want me to hear, yet it seeps through, ignoring his will.

No other Amelia is the same. Each timeline plays out in different ways. Maybe you're fine with blank slates for your companions, but I need a little more than that. Anyway, I'm glad you're enjoying the chitchat, but I'm already sick of talking to you.

Satan rises to his full height, standing just the slightest half-inch taller than me. Our eyes are perfectly level. *The feeling is mutual. You're an incessant reminder that the powers of a god were bestowed upon an unkempt oaf with no concept of how to wield his lofty abilities.*

Yeah? Tell me how you really feel, asshole. How about I take you out with a single word? I'll wipe that stupid look off your face.

How predictable and fitting. It only makes sense you'd know how stupidity looks since you see it in the mirror every time you wake up. Satan's eyes suddenly fly open, and I realize he's about to thoughtsmith. *Erase!*

Undo! Block! I parry his thoughts with my own, attempting to prevent his mind from working.

Clarify! Sleep!

Awake! Rend!

The sides of Satan's right arm start to burst apart from my command, but he smirks again.
Heal! Transform! Blind!

My vision goes dark, and I resist the urge to smile. Satan blinded me? And to think he calls *me* pathetic. *Open! Sever!*

* * *

Everything happens so fast; it's hard for me to wrap my head around what's going on. Satan starts fighting Ionis, and surprisingly holds his own, then the new angel arrival flies over to me but a massive shockwave blasts from the other side of the room, sending the girls and I sprawling together in one big pile.

"Are you okay, Jason?" The woman's voice calls out to me, and I shake the disorientation off. "Y-yeah, what happened?"

Her voice is muddled for a moment as my ears pop. She says something about a barrier? Oh, she's talking to that other Jason. She looks back at me. "Oh dear, sweetheart, you're crushing Belial."

"I am?!" I quickly realize the soft, warm pillow underneath me is actually my girlfriend. I quickly jump to my feet and gasp at the blood running down her face. She's still unconscious from when Satan hit her a minute ago. "Sam! Jesus Chr-" I pause, suddenly realizing the new angel is staring at me. It feels wrong to curse in front of her, as if she's my mother or something. "-Uh, **Heal!** "

The gash across Samantha's forehead clears up, and she coughs faintly, then blinks. "Whud habbed?" Her mouth slurs a little, but I get what she's asking.

"You were hurt. Just lie still, and I'll take care of you, Sam."

"Are you the Seed?" The other Jason starts interrogating Satan, but I try and ignore him. I think he can handle him- whoa! What happened to Ionis?! He was on that rampage earlier, but now he's out cold!

"Jason..." Cassiel moans my name, and I realize she's flopped on her back a few feet away. Wasn't I just holding her before that shockwave hit? How did she get over- no, that doesn't matter. "Yeah, Cass, I'm here." I hop over and pick her up, wincing at the sight of the two scraggly bones sticking out of her back. Her complexion is grey, as if she's at death's door. Then I remember she mentioned a lack of energy earlier. I quickly give her some of mine, but it's as if I were dumping water in a vase with a hole at the bottom. The energy quickly drains out of her body.

The older angel quickly appears at my side. "Greying complexion, clammy skin- where are her wings, young man?"

I grind my teeth painfully together in pity pain. "Satan tore them off."

The woman looks at me like I'm stupid. "Well, get them back on! Use your magic, boy! Angels store energy in their wings! Goodness, why don't you know that?"

"Uhh..." I decide not to answer her question, since it will probably just make me look dumber. Glancing around, I spot the bloodied wings tossed like wet rags over in a far corner. "

Pull. " They drag over to me, making a nasty squishy sound as they drag, but a moment later, I hand Cassiel's limp body to the other angel, and the woman holds my girlfriend gently by her front. With Cass's back exposed to me, I aim my mind at the wings and her back. " **Stitch. Repair. Heal. Soothe.** "

Doing this twice, I manage to attach both wings back and heal the damage, sighing inwardly as they glow once again, and her lifeless grey skin slowly shifts back to its natural cream color. "Cass, are you okay now?"

My eyes flick up to the Jason and Satan, now standing inches apart, glaring into each other's eyes. *What are they doing? Don't tell me they're going to kiss and have a hate-fuck or something.*

Cass nods and coughs again, before shakily standing up. Her legs tremble as if she hasn't walked for five years straight. "Uh... uh... I'll... get back to you... on that."

" **Staff.** " I create a walking stick, big enough that she can wrap both hands around it and lean on it, then I turn my attention back to Samantha. She's conscious, but only somewhat. How the hell did Satan hurt her this badly? A single slap, no matter how strong he is, shouldn't have broken her like this.

There must be a psychological aspect to it. It's not because she was hit, nor was it about how strong Satan's attack was, it's more about the fact that a man she loved attacked her like that- with such vicious rage. He called her a whore. *She must be devastated.*

" **Examine.** " My eyes transform, allowing me to see a series of numbers all over Samantha's body. As if I were playing a video game based on healing a patient, her bodily health shows up as numbers, with 1% being critical condition, and 100% being perfect health. Her entire body scores a 97%. Whatever's ailing her, it's definitely due to the soul.

"Sam. Sam, hey. Wake up." I reach over and gently caress her face. "I'm here for you."

"Uohh..." She groans, and a tear rolls down her face. "I can't believe..."

She doesn't finish her sentence. *You can't believe what, Sam? That Satan attacked you? That he treated you like that? I don't believe it either.*

The angel-lady touches my arm. "Hey, Jason- your name is Jason, right?"

"Yeah. Who're you?"

She smiles, her eyes flicking from Samantha to me. "My name is Helen. We're good friends in every stream, but this is my first time seeing you like this. What's your identifier?"

Again with that 'identifier' talk. That's what the old man asked when he first got here. "I don't know what you're talking about."

Helen nods. "So you're not a clone of Alpha? Where did you come from? Or rather, what do you remember?"

The other Jason and Satan's eyes are wild, as if in their silent glaring there's a war raging between the two of them. I try not to stare, but they've taken another step closer together.

"Um, no offense, but now's probably not the best time."

Helen looks unsure. "If you don't want to say, I respect your privacy. My husband and Jason Alpha are trying to put the pieces together, but I think I know what's going on."

"Jason Alpha? Is that the other 'me' over there?"

"Yes. He's the original- the Source. All Jasons are descendants of his, in one form or another. Perhaps not you, though. I don't know." A nervous expression crosses her face. "You might also be... a fake."

"A *what*?" I stare at her incredulously, and something in my gaze makes her take a step back. "I'm not a fake! What does that even mean?"

"Satan could have..." She trails off but shakes her head. "No, that's not how Satan works. He's too methodical, and he *hates* Jasons. Even if he has some grand plan or scheme, he'd never bring another Jason into existence." Another pause and she glances back at her husband, who's trying to stick his robotic arm back on. "You might just prove my theory about the multiverse."

"What? What?" I ask twice, just to be sure I'm hearing her right. "Multiverse? What are you on about?"

"Oh." Her eyes clear up, as if she's just figured something out. "You don't even know about that. Hold on a moment, sweetheart. I need to talk to my husband, Harold. Comfort your girlfriends."

I nod as she flaps her wings and flies across the room with breathtaking speed, covering forty feet in a single second, landing next to her husband with ease. I've never seen Cassiel fly like

that before. Fast, certainly- but never that level of pure agility.

Cassiel... I glance up at her and notice she's following Helen's every movement with something not unlike awe. She stares for a moment or two, then turns back to me, apparently feeling my gaze on her back. "Helen's an angel."

"Yeah, she is."

"But... she's an angel."

The incredulity in her voice would make me laugh if there weren't an edge of raw emotion to it. That, plus I'm holding Samantha's incoherent body against me. She's still mumbling in her delirium. "Cass, what's on your mind? You want Helen to be your new BFF?"

Cassiel chuckles, but it's half-hearted. "I thought I was the last one. I thought the others were... gone."

Appearing out of nowhere, Helen scares the shit out of me by landing beside Cassiel, catching my startled girlfriend as she staggers back. "You're not the only angel left! Not in this universe, and certainly not in the others." She helps Cassiel sit down on the cold, hard ground, and sighs. "There are a few hundred living in a special dimension that Jason created. We give them regular supplies of energy. They're a little bored, but safe, otherwise. I feel bad for them, but with demons in this universe, we can't be too careful. We'd take them to another stream, but causality and all those other dreadful rules- you know how it is."

Neither Cassiel nor I have any clue what she's talking about, but we both nod dumbly.

The sound of exhaling behind me and to my left catches me by surprise. I turn back and spot Ben Brown, helmet off, leaning against a wall and smoking a cigarette. "I'm in crazy town. Other universes, time travel, clones... maybe I didn't wake up yet. Hell of a dream, though."

"What are you doing smoking at a time like this?" I gawk at him, but Ben rolls his eyes.

"It doesn't matter. Yo, angel lady, Heron or whatever..."

"Helen," she says, correcting him.

"Yeah. What's going on with that Jason and Satan over there?"

I turn back and frown, noticing their faces are incredibly strained, and their noses are almost touching. Before I can comment, Cassiel whispers, "Are they going to make out?"

"I know! That's what I was thinking!" Ben throws his hands up in the air, but Helen coughs and interrupts our weird thoughts.

"I think they're thoughtsmithing at each other. This happens sometimes. I don't see the point."

"Th-thoughtsmithing? What, like, Wordsmithing, but in their minds? *You can do that?!* " My eyes go starry at the possibilities.

With an explosive exit, Jason Alpha and Satan suddenly leap apart, and both of them start gasping as if they had just run fifty triathlons back to back. Sweat pours down their faces.

Jason Alpha wipes at his forehead. "Shit, you think just like your clones. I swear I've done this a thousand times. It's always exhausting."

Satan takes a few seconds longer before mopping at his forehead, as if trying to prove he isn't fazed. "Yes, well, you *stink* like your clones."

From across the room, a voice whimpers, "Satan... First Emperor... help me..." I cringe at the sight of Beelzebub, somehow still alive, his body chopped in half and one of his arms sliced off just above the elbow. Ionis did that to him, which is impressive. I knew the Sentinel was powerful, but Ionis took out the Second Emperor single-handedly. Even for a robot, that's-

"Shut up, insect." Satan jerks his head to the side, glares at Beelzebub, and the Second Emperor screams wordlessly as his body evaporates into mist.

Jason Alpha is surprised. "Whoa. That was cold, even for you."

"He was just a clone. The real one is still alive." Satan waves his hand, and Beelzebub appears next to him, visibly surprised to be there.

While this happens, I realize what Helen told me moments ago, and the reality sinks in. It's not just the existence of Thoughtsmithing, it's that Satan has access to it, and I don't. He has my power, but better. I was outmatched from the very start.

...No. No, that's not true. I may not know what his thoughts are, but is that necessary? Other than a speed increase, would Thoughtsmithing unlock new ways of using Wordsmithing? Everything still boils down to intent. I have something that Satan doesn't... the Crown of Solomon.

Satan and Jason Alpha both continue barking at each other, but I reach up to feel with my hands and confirm the Crown is still there.

It is.

Jason Alpha is overconfident, and Satan is too calm. One of these two has the other outmatched, but they each think the other is a hopeless fool. I can see that much in their eyes.

I have to bide my time. Satan isn't paying any attention to me, now. His eyes are on the one before him. I quickly magic a small mattress into existence and rest Samantha on it, then rise slowly, to not draw the attention of the two Thoughtsmiths.

Sometimes, one strikes while the iron is hot. Other times, waiting is for the best.

Helen watches me, a look of curiosity in her eyes. "Are you up to something?"

"Yeah. I'm sneaking."

Part 471c: Premonition

Satan and Jason Alpha ignore me. Without this "Thoughtsmithing" they probably don't see me as a threat, or one who can tip the balance of a battle. I'm glad, even, since it works out well for me. The most dangerous enemy is one who has been underestimated.

A quick glance behind me reveals Helen sitting down with Cassiel, quietly talking to her about this and that. Ben's cigarette is nearly burnt to the butt, and he watches me silently, while Samantha breathes lightly on the mattress I gave her. I guess she fell asleep.

"Nothing worse than a human, that's what I always say," Satan grumbles at Jason Alpha. "Sadly, you've shown up too soon. I wasn't prepared for your arrival."

Jason Alpha rolls his eyes. "Oh dear, do you want me to leave and come back another time? I wouldn't want to be unfair or anything. Lord knows a *weakling* like you needs all the help he can get."

"Weakling?! Why you insufferable little..." Satan gnashes his teeth, but forces himself to calm down. "How many galaxies have you devoured to fuel that power of yours? For all your talk of being the hero, you're all too willing to destroy sentient life, as am I. You're hardly any better than me."

"Hold on a second; I used my abilities to check for life in each galaxy. By the time a trillion years have passed, and the lack of their existence has any long-term ripples on the universe at large, whatever life does exist will either be dead anyway or will have evolved to handle all the threats. Unlike your clones, who just eat whatever they want, I'm careful."

I have no idea what these two are talking about, but something about Satan's antsiness bugs me. He's planning something, and I don't think the other Jason sees it. The thing is, I don't think it's something that will give him a victory, either. He's going to run away, like a coward.

Satan stretches out his arms, as if opening himself up to an attack. "You can't win. Neither can I. Why bother with the nonsense? You have no way of eliminating all my clones at once since you can't find them, and I cannot eliminate yours. Don't you see the futility in continuing?"

"Of course I do. The thing is, Satan..." Jason Alpha leans forward, and as his cocky smile wavers, a hint of anger surfaces. "...I've been killing clones, not the real thing. If I wipe you out, I'll have my revenge on the Seed, the one who hurt me personally, and Amelia."

Wait, did he just say Amelia? As in, *that* Amelia? The one Hoarhiim killed with a supernova? I must be missing something. What did Satan do to her? Shouldn't the other Jason be angry at me instead? Eh, on second thought, I don't want him pissed at me. Also, there are alternate universes and a bunch of other things that make my head hurt...

The First Emperor closes his arms back up and glances at Beelzebub, on his side opposite me. "The Hero wants revenge. Poetic, isn't it?"

Under my breath, I wordsmith, " **Bug**, " and a tiny insect-shaped spy drone, the size of a fingernail, pops into existence and floats in midair above my hand. It's the same color as Satan's black cloak, and if my estimations are correct, it'll blend in perfectly with his outfit.

Beelzebub nods at Satan's wisecrack. "Very poetic, First Emperor," and my tiny bug flies silently across the room and crawls under one of the folds in Satan's cloak. *Perfect*.

Jason Alpha raises up a finger, and a tiny ball of black energy begins to form. "Remember this?"

A memory the two of them seem to share resurfaces, and Satan raises his eyebrows. "Oh yes, an orb of instant death. I killed your little woman with something just like that, didn't I? How long did it take you to figure out the secret behind it?"

"Not. Long." Jason Alpha enunciates the words slowly, deliberately. "Maybe a few years. I've been waiting to use this on you. That's the secret behind Wordsmithing, isn't it? The caster's intent is all that matters. You can say 'duck' and make a death-bomb appear if you can just get past the mental barriers."

Satan nods. "Or an orb that bypasses all defenses, nullifies barriers created by another wordsmith, and blows out the chest of the one he loves. Your point? I suppose you're going to hit me with that and kill me, right? More poetic justice from the esteemed Hero."

"Correct." I suddenly notice a look in Jason Alpha's eye, something that tells me he doesn't like the word *hero*. Is that why Satan keeps saying it? Is he taunting that version of me? Does Jason Alpha think he's not worthy of being called a Hero, or is there some other reason for his disdain?

"Go ahead, then. Do it. But, first, let me introduce you to my friends." The very instant Satan says *friends*, Jason Alpha lobbs the tiny sphere, and it smacks right into Satan's chest, but passes through a microsecond later, as Satan vanishes. He reappears, along with a dozen, no, dozens of other clones of himself. Fifty at least, by my quick estimation! The room expands outward by some unnatural force, allowing the different Satans to fill the space, and all of them speak in unison.

" Greetings, Jason Hiro. We are Satan. We are one. You may kill us, but more will take our place. The Seed is among us, but which is he? "

Jason Alpha takes a step back in surprise. "Clones? Big deal. I've got clones too." A moment later, dozens of other Jasons appear, one for each of the Satans opposite them.

Two tiny armies, each one capable of destroying a universe, face off against the other. But something isn't right. The Satans all stand uniformly, each mimicking the other in perfect unison, effortlessly, as if they were one mind. On the other hand, some of the Jasons slouch, while others stand at attention. Their hair styles are all different, as are their clothes. A few of them have beards, while most don't. It's as if I'm looking at fifty possibilities for what I'll become later in life.

All of the Satan clones smirk in unison. **" You have copies, but they are different. We are one, coordinating together. We have powers you could only dream of. The greatest heroes of past ages fell before us, and we took their powers from each of them- one by one. I don't suppose you've heard of Hercules? "**

Jason Alpha starts to shake his head, but a scraggly clone in the back with long hippie hair and pink mustache nods excitedly. "Ah yeh, I heard about him, bruv! He was the first Hero ever! Cool guy, met him at one point and we splashed a few beers down, had a good laugh!"

All of the Jasons, myself included, try not to make eye contact with that weirdo. I shudder at the thought I might end up looking or acting like him, ever.

The Satan clones smile. **" He gave us our most potent ability. The ability to share minds. Your clones are uncoordinated and oafish, while mine work together toward a singular goal. "**

Jason Alpha's had enough of Satan's backtalk. "You think a hivemind is a good thing? My clones all have different areas of expertise, and many things they're adept at! While we diversify, you stagnate! I think it's time we end this."

While the two groups argue, I reach inside my mind and touch base with the bug from before. It's a damn good thing I tagged Satan before he split up.

Aha! There he is!

I point my finger toward the third row of Satan's at one five from the left. "Alpha! That one's the Seed!"

The Satan I pointed at jerks his head over to me. "What? How could you have-"

"Attack!" Jason Alpha raises his finger in the air, as do all of his clones, forming those tiny balls of black energy from before. A second later, the orbs laser forward at nearly the speed of

light, ripping apart the front rows of the Satan horde. Some of the devils shimmer and shift, allowing the orbs to pass through, but most aren't so lucky. A few heads are blown off, and just when it looks hopeless for Satan, several Jason clones yell out as something invisible grabs them and lashes them around, smashing them against the walls with terrific force.

Oh! Tiny Satan clones, the size of ants, stand amidst the feet of the Jason clones, using their own thoughtsmithing to attack the giants above them.

"At your feet! Look down!" I point at them, and immediately the other Jasons jump into the air, hover to stay up, and start blasting energy shots at their feet, cratering the ground with incredible force.

Mayhem! The ground shakes with the force of an angry rhino, and I struggle to stay on my feet. Jason Alpha grabs for the Satan I pointed out earlier, not realizing he's already swapped places with a different one of his clones. "Gotcha!" He pounds his fist into that Satan's face, though the clone teleports free and sends one of his black-orb energy shots at Jason Alpha from behind. The orb connects, blasting his rib-cage outward, but Alpha heals the wound with thoughtsmithing hardly a second later and doesn't show any reaction to the damage. He's a monster!

My eyes laser in on the real Satan, skulking in the back, letting his clones fight the Jason clones. That scummy little-! Where is his honor?! " **Teleport.** "

I catch the real Satan off-guard by teleporting him to me, then Wordsmithing again. " **Bind! Confuse!** "

With his body suddenly tied painfully together by invisible chains, and his mind confused, he won't be able to thoughtsmith so I can-

"You can't spit the words out fast enough, Wordsmith! The mind is faster than the tongue!" Satan spins around and grabs me by my throat, gagging me so I can't talk. His grip is strong enough to crush my larynx! Hack! I can't breathe!

No matter how I thrash, I can't make him let go! Jason Alpha is fighting off Satan clones, he hasn't seen me- he can't- oh god, help! Fuck, get this demon off me! Get him... get him off me...

My vision's going black. Ah, Satan's draining my energy. My arms just went limp. This is the end for me. Spots dance in front of my eyes. *I was wrong. A mere Wordsmith can't compete with a Thoughtsmith... it's impossible.*

Satan suddenly yelps in surprise, releasing me as a colossal wave of blinding light smashes into him, pounding him viciously across the room, knocking his and Jason Alpha's clones apart like bowling pins, embedding him a tenth of a mile into the demonstone walls. I cough weakly

and glance up, spotting Cassiel, hands extended, hitting Satan with an unthinkable amount of energy.

"Get your hands off my boyfriend!"

"Tha... thann..." I try to gasp a word out to thank her, but my throat is in bad condition. I taste blood, and the urge to vomit is overtaking me. I trip forward and nearly fall on my face, but Cassiel catches me.

A blessed wave of healing energy quickly heals my throat, and I look up at Cassiel's smiling face. "You saved me, so I'm just returning the favor, sweetie-pie." It's a little weird hearing her call me a pet-name, but... whatever works!

As she helps me to my feet, an angry scream from across the room catches my attention. Satan Prime bursts from the wall where Cassiel sent him, but a massive chunk of the right side of his body is missing, including his arm and some of his ribcage. Satan wheezes, and blood drips from his mouth as he shakily points his remaining arm at my girlfriend. "Y-you... filthy... disgusting angel... kah..."

Cassiel quickly lowers her head and sniffs her armpit. "Filthy? Are you sure about that? You're the one covered in blood."

The Jasons and Satans pick their remaining allies up and watch Satan Prime cautiously as he stumbles toward us. "I should... should have killed them all... every last one of the angels. I took pity on them, and look... look what came of it."

Blood spurts from the missing chunk of his body, and Cassiel squirms. "You should have someone look at that. It could turn infected."

"Piss off." Satan spits the words out, along with a little bit of blood. He glances at his missing arm and a moment of pain washes over his face. It seems odd to me that his arm isn't healing, as if he's trying to repair the damage but he can't. "Holy energy. For an angel to have amassed the amount you have- even to surpass the power Gabriel once had... you're a threat. I won't forget your face." Satan coughs again, and a second later, he vanishes. All of his clones in the room glare at Cassiel before turning away and disappearing as well.

The two dozen remaining Jason clones eye Cassiel with reverence, and Alpha stomps over to us. "Nice work, Cass. What did you do to him?"

She blushes. "I didn't do anything special, and he escaped anyway. Why did you let him go?"

Jason Alpha glances at me and nods. "You saw it too, didn't you? Satan always heals any wound within one second. He didn't repair the damage Cassiel dealt to him. I've never seen him or his clones in that condition. It's worth letting him go to figure out what happened."

Helen stands up and brushes off her robes. "Jason, sweetheart, did it occur to you that he might be faking his injury? I think he wants you to believe there's a way to take him out completely that he can't resist."

"Yeah. Maybe." Jason Alpha sounds unsure. "He mentioned 'holy energy'. Is that something unique to angels?"

"I don't know, unfortunately. I'm just a pseudo-angel." Helen shakes her head slowly. "One of the purebloods from another stream would probably know."

"Hmm..." Jason Alpha trails off, then waves a dismissive hand at his clones. "Thanks for the help. You guys kicked ass."

All of the clones nod or mumble acknowledgment, then teleport away, one by one. Where are they going? Perhaps back to their universes? Am I getting that right?

Jason Alpha starts pacing back and forth. "Good work, you guys. I'm sorry that we had to meet under these circumstances, but don't beat yourself up over how it ended. I've been fighting Satan's clones for like, a billion years or something." He chuckles, then pauses to frown, before resuming his pacing. "Yeah... it's been a long road. So, Jason... Jason uh... you don't have an identifier, right?"

He's talking to me. "No. At least, I don't think so."

Alpha pauses to look at Helen meaningfully. "No identifier... black skin with tattoos... and he's in my Source universe. What do you think that could mean?"

Helen shrugs, as if she hasn't given it a single thought, despite what she said earlier. "Oh, I don't know. If he isn't one of your clones, then he could be a different kind of Jason."

Harold comes stumbling over to us, having hidden behind a wall during the battle. He drags his arm along before reaching up and slapping it against Alpha's chest. "Jiminy crickets. Fix this damn thing. Obviously, the kid comes from yer Source universe. The one from before you rewound."

After a few moments pass, Alpha reaches up, sets the arm back on Harold's 'shoulder' (or whatever one would call his robotic appendage), and it rapidly repairs itself thanks to his thoughtsmithing. "He might be Hope."

Helen inhales sharply. "You told us that Hope was the ultimate evil, possibly worse than Satan."

"To be fair, I said that before I'd fully comprehended the danger that a thoughtsmithing Satan posed to the Multiverse." Jason Alpha gives Harold a light smack on the back. "Good as

new. Anyway, this guy can't be Hope. He's too nice. For one thing, Hope hated Cassiel and Belial. He killed them."

Memories of Hope slowly return to me, opening up as he speaks. "I know who Hope is, but what do you mean when you say he killed Cassiel and Samantha? They're perfectly fine."

Jason Alpha stares at me solemnly for a moment. "You... don't remember? I guess your arrival here is different from mine, after all. I time traveled backward to try and change the past after he brutally murdered the women I loved." Alpha glances at Cassiel, then at Samantha. "That was a long time ago. An eternity. No offense, but I don't really have those feelings anymore."

"It's fine," Cassiel assures him. "I'm a one-guy kind of girl."

"You're tolerant too, given you don't mind Jason being with you and another girl at the same time. I admire that." Jason Alpha looks away, a cloudiness covering his face. "You know, I used to wonder what happened to Hope after I time-traveled. Did he stay behind? Did my rewind change the course of history? Maybe that stream vanished once I left."

Helen coughs. "My theories are a little more nuanced than that."

Harold walks over and wraps an arm around his wife's waist. "Helen thinks this kid's from the Cryopod you used to have installed in my bay. 'Member that? I was still in that orb of yours. Whatever happened to that thing, anyway? And the Hordavimp feller?"

"Oh... Hoarhiim. Yeah, his orb, that's right..." Jason Alpha shrugs. "I left it in the Labyrinth at some point. Stuck it on a pedestal. I was letting the future play out, back then. If I knew then what I know now... well, maybe I wouldn't have done that."

It's my turn to surprise him. " **Storage.** " I quickly reach inside and pluck out Hoarhiim's orb, though as usual it only glows a soft yellow. I still remember when he died and how it tore my heart apart, yet it's as if he's still alive inside, waiting to be released. "Does this look familiar?"

Jason Alpha glances at me, then back to the orb. "Oh, interesting. How long have you had his orb?"

Minutes pass as I regale Jason Alpha with tales of my adventures, though occasionally Helen interrupts me to tell me my memories aren't quite matching up with reality. She lives in this universe, while her husband and Alpha travel around, so she's experienced things they haven't.

"But there was a supernova... right?" I ask her, as she corrects me yet again.

Helen nods. "Yes, that part is correct, young man. I heard the stories about it several years ago from one of my friends among the orcs."

I pause to look at Jason Alpha. "I thought you loved Amelia, though? Why didn't you save her from the supernova if that was the case?"

He nods. "I did. Well, I *do*, rather. I was trapped in this idea that the future would repeat itself with or without my intervention, and so it did. Helen has her theories on time travel, but some things are still unknown. I didn't save the woman I loved, not even from you... because I thought that if I did, she'd die just like Benjamin Brown, over and over again. I wanted to spare her such a fate." He glances over at Ben. "Well, you know what I mean."

"Uh huh," Ben says, unamused. "I heard the guy I was cloned from dodged death a hundred times, only to kick the bucket in the end. Makes you wonder how I've survived. Maybe clones are exempt from causality?"

Jason Alpha taps a watch on his wrist, and several weird holographic images pop up that I can barely wrap my head around. "Yeah, maybe. Anyway, I need to get going. I've gotta track Satan Prime down, so I'm going to make a pit stop and chat with my friends at the Time and Space Council, and see what we can do to find him." Alpha looks me right in the eye. "And we need to figure out who, or what, you are."

I give him my most innocent smile. "Still think I'm Hope? Don't you have any faith in me?"

"I'm just keeping an open mind." Jason Alpha taps his wrist to turn off the holograms. "Anyway, I'll be back in three RTU's. That's *Real Time Units* for the uninitiated. Harold, you're coming with me. Helen, you should stay behind and keep these kids company. I'm sure they have questions."

The older lady smiles with over-the-top saccharine sweetness at Jason Alpha. "Oh, you never let me have any fun. Still, you have a point... This young lady over here hasn't seen another angel in ages. Perhaps I'll introduce her to her missing family." Helen looks past Alpha at the place where he was fighting Satan several minutes ago. "By the way, what happened to that robot Satan was fighting?"

A silence falls across us as we glance around. From the darkness, Beelzebub suddenly emerges, a stupidly evil grin on his face. "You just noticed? And here I thought your bumbling cavalcade of idiocy might forget it entirely. The First Emperor took the Sentinel with him, of course. And now that he's gone, that makes me... the First Emperor. Heh heh heh."

Beelzebub grins at us for several moments, until I break the silence. "You know Alpha here can kill you instantly, right? Cassiel nearly blew Satan to kingdom come by herself, so I'm pretty sure you'd be no problem for her. I'd keep the evil laughter to a minimum if I were you."

The smile shatters. Beelzebub's shoulders sag forward, and his face melts into a puddle of disgust. "Curse you and everything for which you stand. Can't you let me have my moment of

gloating? I fought for years, trying to climb my way to the top, and now that I have it, you can't give me five minutes of satisfaction?"

I feel kinda bad for Beelzebub. After all that he's been through, he arrives at the top of the food chain, only to realize he's entirely powerless, even compared to just his predecessor. After seeing the previous First Emperor get the living shit beaten out of him by our little group, Beelzebub has realized that if Satan couldn't beat us, then he doesn't stand a chance either.

Jason Alpha swaggers over to the newly minted First Emperor and slugs him playfully on the shoulder. "Oh, cheer up! This is the first universe I've seen you in for a long time, old buddy! Look at how you climbed the ladder of power! I'm proud of you!"

"I'd sooner die than listen to your condescension." Beelzebub rubs the spot where Alpha knuckled him, but he doesn't seem as angry as before. Rather, he's somewhat depressed. "To think, the First Emperor stole his lofty powers from humans. I never, in all my life-!" He trails off into a string of foul words that don't befit him, and all we can do is sigh.

Samantha stirs behind me and sits up to lean against the wall. "Beelzebub, ahh... perhaps it's time you rethought what your values are." She rubs her head and I only just now realize a bruise is forming on her face. "I've been trying to tell you this whole time that things aren't black and white. You can change demon society, just as you wanted to, but for the better."

For once, Beelzy doesn't call Samantha a human-lover or any other insult. He just bows his head and sighs. "You want demons to ally with humans. A stupid idea, if there ever was one. Our differences are too great to reconcile."

"I don't know about that," Alpha says, as he leans against the wall beside Ben. "I've seen a lot of universes. Many where I killed Satan early in the timeline eventually turn out reasonably okay. The four species aren't so different when you think about it. Two arms, two legs, two eyes, a mouth, hair, lungs, and a humanoid appearance. Monsters are the odd ones, but even they have similar characteristics. Once you get past the physical differences, it's only politics and grudges that divide us."

Beelzebub rolls his eyes. "I see that a few million years will improve your vocabulary, but won't do much for your reasoning skills. Maybe in those other universes demons and humans can shake hands and smile at each other, but those universes are not this one."

Samantha carefully pulls herself up to her feet. "Beelzebub, I think you're the one with the poor reasoning skills. Forgiveness isn't a sign of weakness, but of strength. To forgive the past, you have to let go of your hatred, and that takes strength. If you want to be a powerful leader, respected among your peers... then you should redefine what 'strength' means. Once you do

that, the limitations you feel right now will disappear, and you will reach new heights that neither Satan nor Diablo ever could."

Helen claps all of a sudden, startling me. "She speaks wisdom, Beelzebub! You'll have more success redefining what it means to be a successful demon than fighting a war you can't win."

With a slow nod, Beelzebub turns away. "Your ideas have merit, but I can't bring myself to forgive humans, and especially Jason, for that matter. I'll never forget my humiliation."

It occurs to me what I've been misunderstanding all along about Beelzebub. It's not just his hatred of humans, but the consequences of my actions that have steeled his mind against rational thought. He's been wronged, and his response is to lash out at those who humiliated him.

Well, I know who caused all this.

Carefully, I take a step toward him. "Beelzebub, you know, I'm not asking you to forget what I did to you, but I think I owe you an apology. I don't want to give out any excuses, but in human years, I was one-third my current age. I made a lot of mistakes, and I'm sorry I did what I did. Killing you, just to bring you back and make you my servant was incredibly short-sighted and selfish of me."

I extend my hand toward the demon-emperor, and Beelzebub stares at it like it's a radioactive isotope. "You're apologizing? What purpose does that serve?"

"Humans apologize when they wrong each other. An apology is just a series of words, but it's what comes afterward- our actions, that determine if those words had any meaning. I'm not just going to apologize... I'm going to try and do what I can to repair the damage I've caused. Both to you, and to demons as a whole."

Faint electricity seems to jump from my outstretched hand to Beelzebub's eyes, as he continues to stare at it. Nobody says anything as they wait for his response.

"Reconciling with a human; something I've never done before. I don't want to do so now, but at the same time..." Beelzebub trails off and looks away, before catching me by surprise as he jerks and shoves his hand into mine, then shakes. "Devil's sake. Are all humans as melodramatic as you?"

Samantha exhales audibly. "No, that's a special trait of Jason's. You're doing the right thing, Beelzebub."

He quickly pulls his hand from mine, then wipes it on his suit jacket. "If you say so. I'm not so certain." He pauses a moment before turning away. "What I am, however, is a demon of honor. I never go back on my word. I'll at least consider your request."

Without saying goodbye, Beelzebub slowly walks away, fading into the darkness of the Labyrinth as we watch in silence.

Jason Alpha is the first to speak, once Beelzebub is gone. "Don't hate Beelzebub. He's one of the few who regularly breaks his mold. Most beings are good or evil across the entire multiverse, but he's been helpful on several occasions." Alpha licks his lips, then glances down at a device on his wrist. "Anyway. Harold, you and I need to start tracking Satan down. Knowing him, he'll try and slip away again, but we can catch him this time by following the trail Cassiel gave us."

Cass perks up. "The trail? Which one?"

Alpha points at a blip on his holo-watch. "You hit him with Holy Energy. Those wounds weren't repaired immediately, so that means he probably couldn't heal them. No way he'd leave himself exposed like that. The miasma leaking from his body will leave a trail across the multiverse I can easily follow. There's also the Sentinel he stole. I'd prefer not to take any chances on him figuring out how to reactivate it since he has all the time in the multiverse. Well, I do too, but that's beside the point."

I don't get a chance to ask what he means by that last part, because Harold jumps in. "Yeap, I figured ye'd wanna leave soon. Are ya sure ya don't want to stay for a day or two, then bounce later?"

"Nah. Now's fine. We'll come back soon, guys." He addresses the group with the final phrase, before patting Harold on the back and pulling the grandpa away from his wife. "As for you, other-Jason-guy... man, I need to give you an identifier. How about Sparky?"

"I'll pass," I say, dryly.

"Whatever you say, Sparky. Anyway, we'll be back in a few days, your time. I'll let you know when we catch him."

Ben chuckles. "You think you can catch him in three days? You're better than I thought."

"Huh? No, it'll probably take a few years, but I could return a minute from now if I wanted. You know how time works when you're a Traveler, right, buddy?"

Everyone except for Helen and Harold shake their heads.

"Oh, right. You guys are- never mind. It's too much of a hassle to explain. I'll tell you later." Jason Alpha grips Harold's shoulder, then winks at me. "See you later, space cowboy."

He and the old man vanish in a flash of light, leaving me to wonder what he meant by those parting words.

* * *

"Huuaah!" Tvoorik screams in his sleep all of a sudden, making me jerk up and smash my head on his cot above me. Just as I cringe and start rubbing the bump, the dumbass flops over and falls off his bed, smashing into the floor below. "Ahhh! It hurts! The pain!"

"Yeah, 'the pain' is right. Why are you hollering like that?! You're going to wake up everyone for ten sectors around if you keep-"

"Death! Destruction! An invasion from above! Like a wave of anguish, they'll sweep over us and take us for all we've got!" Tvoorik rolls around on the ground, whooping and shouting, and I quickly glance at the doorway. Any second now, the Lord who runs our sleeping division is going to arrive with that flaming whip of hers and give us a real lashing.

I quickly hop out of bed and deliver a gut-wrenching kick right to my idiot friend's stomach, knocking the wind out of him. His shouting instantly silences and he instead starts gasping for breath.

"Shut up, dumbass! Get ahold of yourself!" I quickly erect a barrier at the doorway to stifle the sound from our room, but I'm awful with magic so it'll probably only last a few minutes at best. If we're lucky, most of the other demons will roll back over, grumble a bit, and go to bed.

A minute later, Tvoorik finally opens his eyes and manages to suck in a gasp of air, before he glares at me. "Foul fiend! Why hath thou attacked me with thy unbidden rage?"

"Stop talking like that. You sound like an idiot pretending to be smart." I reach down and hoist my 'friend' up to his feet and lean him against the wall. "So you wanna tell me why you started howling like a banshee during sleeping hours? Lord Whipmaster wouldn't take kindly to you waking her up like the last fifty times."

Tvoorik rubs his forehead and moans quietly. "Oh, Ylvusk... it was bad... real bad. A nightmare, but I was there like it wasn't a dream at all. Geez, being a Seer sucks. I just know it had to be the future I saw."

"The future? Are you still going on about that nonsense?" I pause, remembering that it was an Emperor who told him what his ability entailed. If an Emperor says he can see the future, it's probably true. "Well, don't keep me waiting! What happens in the future?"

My friend nods glumly, a look of sadness etched in his eyes. "W-well, I saw a big army... they weren't demons, or humans, or angels, or volgrim... they were all of them together."

"Uh huh."

"And th-they had these scary weapons that could shoot big lasers, and there were a bunch of spaceships flying around this weird portal thing- and also an army of green-people who were spitting into the mouths of demons nearby, and there was also-"

I interrupt him. "You're losing me, Tvoorik. Green people? Spitting into mouths? What the hell are you going on about?"

He crumples his face up and slumps to the ground. "Aw, geez, Ylvusk. I don't know. The monsters were scary. Even the First Emperor would have trouble fighting them off. I saw how they turned demons and humans and all the others into monsters too. We kept losing, couldn't win a single battle."

"Well, that's grim, but it's just a dream. Even if it's a vision of the future, time isn't set in stone." I lean down to his level and am shocked to see tears rolling down his face. Tvoorik has always been a pretty upbeat guy, even when I called him an idiot or other stuff like that. Whatever he saw, it's hitting him hard.

"Y-you think so? You think we can win?" Tvoorik wipes at his eyes but the tears keep coming. "Shucks, she was so beautiful, too."

"She? Who?"

"The angel-lady. There was a beautiful angel, and all I felt was happiness whenever she appeared. She protected us from the monsters."

This change of scenery almost makes me laugh. "Beautiful, huh? What parts of her got you all hot and heavy? Maybe this dream is because you can't get a girlfriend, hehe."

Tvoorik doesn't smile or return the laugh. "It wasn't like that, Ylvusk. She was beautiful in a pure way. Like a... like a broodmother, or something."

I raise an eyebrow at the comparison. "Maybe it's been a while since you went to the Spawning Pits, but I think you've forgotten what broodmothers look like. Those giant, bulbous asses, big enough to spit out a fully-grown orc once every few months... the six hundred razor-sharp teeth, the ten eyes... man, no wonder you can't get a lady. Your standards for beauty are way off-

"I get it, geez! You know that's not what I meant!" Tvoorik glowers at me before turning his head away. "I hate being a Seer. I wish I'd never evolved. I know what every demon in the area is dreaming about, and their dreams mix with mine, and it gets all confusing... I can't even sort my own thoughts out! I can barely even think anymore!"

My friend is in pain. I can joke around and tease him all I like, but he's turning more unstable as time passes. Now he thinks green aliens are going to vomit in our mouths and convert us to their species or something. Then he starts developing mommy issues, and his head's going to explode if the pressure gets any worse.

"Maybe we should go chat with Diablo. He might know how to deal with your problems. Maybe he has magic that will turn your brain off while you sleep."

Tvoorik sniffles. "You think so, bestest buddy?"

"Uh huh. Let's go and talk to him. Diablo's a smart guy. I'm sure he knows a few people."

My friend and I share a smile, and for the first time in a while, everything feels like it's going to be okay.

"Hey, you worthless maggots!" A voice from the doorway makes him and I jump. I jerk my head to the left to look, and it's Lord Whipmaster! Shit! "You woke me up, stupid morons! I was having a great dream until your stupid voices screamed down the hallway!"

"S-sorry?" I offer a weak apology and swallow as she uncoils her whip of fire. *Oh no.*

"Yeah, you'll be real devil-damned sorry when I'm done with you two!"

Broodmommy, give us the endurance to survive.

Part 472c: Murderer

A waning sun in the sky illuminates the streets of Hero City enough that the boy and girl can just barely make out the faces of the shopkeepers closing up their stalls for the day. A cold breeze blows down the streets, an artificial effect created by the god who formed this world in the past ages.

"It's just up the street, Alex," The girl says. Her curly brown hair bounces around every time she takes a step, and her high-heeled boots click against the cobblestone streets. Despite her stunning good-looks, she isn't particularly upbeat or perky. Indeed, her eyes dart from the left to the right as she walks, observing nearby doorways and people walking around.

"You're sure he's over here? Mum says not to go far from home..." Alex trails off, unsure how to stand up for himself. He turned ten a few weeks ago, so resisting a pretty girl is harder for him than it used to be. Plus, with her big thick-rimmed glasses, the girl looks a lot like his teacher from school. *Always do what the teacher tells you*, he thinks, remembering his mother's words from a few years before. He's a good boy, so he always does what he's told.

"It's just a block away, silly! Surely you've gone this far without asking your mother." The girl teases him, but there's an edge to her voice. "I saw the man up here. You said he was from your church?"

"Uh-huh," Alex replies. "Mister Jones. He hasn't been heard from in a week..." Alex swallows, remembering the stories he's heard about a vicious demon on the loose abducting people and experimenting on them while they begged for help. Still, as the Divine Mother told him, *not all demons are bad*, and she even said her best friend was a demon! *Yeah, I can't treat all demons like they're evil*, Alex thinks, as he glances carefully up at the side of the girl's face. Most demons have blood-red skin, but hers is creamy, just like his. Her eyes have that red tone that all demons possess, but somehow they also make him feel good when she looks at him.

The girl slows to a stop and turns to look down a dark alley. "Mister Jones is right that way." She points at a garbage can shrouded in the dim light between the two buildings. A man's leg and shoe are visible behind the can as if he's sleeping in the only place available.

Alex trembles slightly. "M-mister Jones? Mister Jones!" He calls out, but the man doesn't respond. "Rosie, I'm... I'm scared of the dark."

"Oh, come on. It's not even dark, Alex. You can see in there and everything. Just go wake him up!" She gives Alex a nudge forward, but his knees shake a little.

"I really don't wanna..."

Rosie sighs audibly as if Alex is just being a big baby. Okay, fine, I'll light it up for us." With a quick movement of her hands, she holds her palm up, and a small flame appears, suspended in midair. It pierces up the growing darkness enough that Alex can even see the dimples on her face.

The boy takes a step back in surprise. "You... you can make f-fire?"

"It's just magic, Alex. All demons have magic, you know." Her smile cracks ever so slightly as she glances at the bum sleeping behind the dumpster. "Of course, some demons mutate and gain offensive magic and lots of energy while others gain useless seduction and illusion arts, but beggars can't be choosers, as they say."

Alex nods, but the uneasiness in his stomach doesn't go away. With the girl behind him, he slowly creeps toward the old man. "Mister Jones? Are you okay?" As he nears the dumpster, Alex spots the man's other leg, though something about it looks unnatural. The bottom half of the pant leg is missing, and his foot isn't turned the right way. A shiver goes down Alex's back as he creeps forward and sees the man's body. Despite Rosie's flame, she's far enough behind him that the dumpster blocks most of the light... but Mister Jones looks an awful lot like he's...

"A pity this is all the flame I can manage," the girl mutters. "Mister Beelzebub would be very very disappointed in me."

Alex opens his mouth, but he can't bring himself to speak. Tears form and slowly crawl down his face as Rosie walks a little closer and the light from the flame finally illuminates the old man's desiccated corpse. His entire right arm is missing, along with most of his face. The wall behind him is covered in dried blood, and chunks of his body can be seen here and there.

"H-he... he... he-" Alex stutters uncontrollably, barely able to get a word out. "Muh-mister J-J-Jones..." His stomach flips and spins inside of him and every bone in his body screams to run, but the spasming horror in his body prevents him from moving. The alley is a dead end. The only way to escape is to run past the girl with the fire in her hand.

"Dead, yes. I killed him, of course." Rosie trots forward, grabs Alex by his shirt with her free hand, then yanks his shivering body toward her. With the flame in her other hand, she plunges the ball of fire into his throat, causing Alex to scream, but the sound doesn't escape his mouth as the skin and muscle below it melt together. She tosses Alex lightly, sending him flying twenty feet down the alley, where he smashes against a wall and flops to the ground, writhing in pain.

I can't breathe! I can't breathe! Help! Help me, Mum!! Alex's internal voice screams as Rosie's high-heeled boots click toward him, but no matter how he tries, he can't force a sound out. The smell of his own melting flesh fills his nostrils, and the pain is just seconds from

causing him to blackout. Alex realizes with a start that this is how Mister Jones must have felt. *She's the demon! She's killing everyone! I should have listened! Mum! Mum, help me!*

She kneels down and pats the boy on the back. "It's been three weeks since I caught a kid alone, Alex. Your friend, Susie... she gave me a lot of energy, you know. Old men and women don't transfer much- and they always taste like tobacco or alcohol. Once I consume your essence, I'll surely mutate into something more powerful. After that happens Mister Beelzebub will have to acknowledge me." Her cheeks turn a rosy red as she imagines the passionate embrace he'll surely give her once she's revealed her murderous deeds. *'How good of you to kill the filthy humans, my beloved. I always knew you had it in you.'*

Alex cranes his head up and tries to beg for mercy. His mouth opens, but no words come out. *I'm sorry! I'm sorry! Please don't hurt me! Please, it hurts! Make it stop!*

"Your first mistake was getting my name wrong. 'Rosie' is not a noble name, Alex. Beelzebub would never love a demoness whose name gave such a feeling of peasantry. It's Rosalia. *Ro-sal-ia*. " She hisses out her name the second time and glares at the boy before violently lunging her hand forward and slapping him, sending him smashing against a wall.

This time, her blow leaves Alex crumpled and broken in a corner. His right arm and several ribs shatter, but he can't feel the pain anymore. Unable to breathe, unable to feel pain, the world darkens before him. He stares at her silently as she trudges forward, glancing behind herself to look for witnesses. *Nobody's there*, Alex realizes. The two of them are all alone.

He blinks one last time as she kneels down and opens her mouth. "Thank you for dinner!"

A warmth covers his body. As his eyes close, a strange thought enters his mind. *She disappeared. Just like I will.*

He didn't deserve to die like this. Alex knows that much, but the world is unfair. Sometimes the weak and innocent are murdered by those with more power. If only he'd listened to his Mum, it could all have been-

A strange feeling enters his body all of a sudden. Reflexively, Alex coughs, and spits blood all over the ground before inhaling sharply. His throat is healed! Alex's eyes shoot open, and he screams out loud, unable to control himself.

It takes a moment for him to understand what he's looking at. He's still in the alley, but the walls drip with a horrific amount of blood. Entrails and bone litter the corridor, and Alex stares in shock at his body, noticing that the blood is all over himself as well, but it isn't his.

"Alex? Alex! Are you okay?" A familiar voice calls to him, and he glances up and spots a familiar face. "D-Divine Mother?"

Cassiel, the Divine Mother, stands just in front of him, tears streaming down her face. "Oh, thank the heavens! I'm here for you; I'm here!" She quickly leans down and hugs him, picking him up in the process and pulling him away from the scene of the carnage. "It's okay; she's gone. She's gone. She won't hurt you, Alex."

The boy nods as terror and exhilaration give way to numbness. For some reason, he can't feel any emotions. Everything that just happened to him feels distant, as if it happened to one of his friends from school. "Thank you... Divine Mother."

A moment later, she lowers Alex to the ground and quickly pulls his eye open, and scrutinizes his figure. Alex notices her white robes are filthy and covered with blood, likely from when she picked him up and carried him. "No broken bones, no lacerations... how do you feel, Alex?"

"I'm sure he's fine, Cass." A man's voice from behind Alex frightens him, and he jumps forward and cowers near the warmth of the Divine Mother and the light her body produces naturally. Alex's eyes jerk to the source of the voice, and he spots the figure of the God-King, the almighty deity who formed the angels with the power of a single word. The God-King smiles at Alex, then looks over at the Divine Mother. "Christ, we're lucky we made it. That satellite was a good investment."

"Jason, now's not the time." The Divine Mother's voice has a tone of caution in it, and Alex realizes she's worried about him. "Hurry up and clean him. You don't want the boy to be scarred for life, do you?"

"Scarred?" Alex echoes her choice of words, not sure what she means. "Where's Rosie? What happened to Rosie?"

"Rosie?" The God-King raises an eyebrow. "Is that the name of the demon who attacked you?"

"Uh huh..." Alex curls up into a ball as the memories come rushing back. The cold, flat expression on her face, and the way she eyed him as a piece of meat give Alex spasms as he suddenly fights the urge to vomit.

"Clean. Calm." The man says two words, and suddenly Alex's nausea vanishes, along with the entrails covering his body. Alex stares at the ground for a moment, thinking silent thoughts. *I want to cry, but I can't. I want to scream, but I can't. I want my Mum.*

"Jason, stop using your powers as a band-aid. Let the boy cry." The Divine Mother helps Alex to his feet, before slowly walking him away from the alley. "Let's get you home, Alex. Where does your mother live?"

Thoughts come to Alex more easily than he thinks they should. "Five blocks away, Divine Mother, to the North. What about Mister Jones?"

The angel smiles quickly, as if to assure him that everything is all right. "Um, we'll give him help, okay? You just worry about yourself for now. I'll take care of everything."

I'll take care of everything, Alex thinks, echoing her words in his mind.

A few minutes later, Alex steps into his house, and his mother weeps as she praises and lauds the Divine Mother and the God-King for saving her son, but Alex can barely understand her through all of the crying and wailing. While his mother sobs and thanks the heavens, all the boy can do is stare blankly at the wall behind her.

It's the only thing he can feel, as that familiar numbness overtakes him, once again.

* * *

Cassiel sighs as we walk away from the kid's house. "What a mess. I haven't seen horrors like that outside of war."

I nod as the memory of the walls covered in blood surfaces in my mind. "My satellite worked perfectly, but it's a shame about the old man. He must have died a week ago before I built it. Does the name 'Rosie' ring any bells?"

My girlfriend shakes her head as I teleport us back to the castle. "I have a vague memory, but nothing concrete. Anyway, your death machine killed her, so I guess it doesn't matter anymore."

I pause to talk to a guard at the castle entrance, informing him of the murder, and he promises to dispatch a team to clean the alley up and bury the old man's body. Then, I turn back to Cassiel. "If Rosie was the only killer, then we're fine, but there may be more of them. Kinda hard to interrogate a corpse." I pause, searching her face. "Also, that 'death machine' saved the poor kid's life. If it hadn't vaporized her, then pinged me, he'd be dead."

"I know, I know." Cassiel sulks for a moment. "You should build another satellite."

"Come again?"

"You heard me. This time, build a first-response satellite that stuns the attacker. That should be possible, right? Just suppress their neural stimulation and agitate the relevant-" Cassiel pauses, seeing a smile on my face. "What? Did I say something funny?"

"You're such a nerd, Cass. But yeah, I'll do that. Good idea. Another option is police-bots to patrol the streets, but the idea creeps me out." I wave at Samantha and Helen as we head over to them.

Samantha's worried expression melts away as I give her a quick hug. "You guys left in a hurry. One second you were here, the next you said "Teleport," and then Cass vanished along with you. What gives?"

"Sorry, it was an emergency. I would've brought you and Helen along but..." I pause, realizing I'll sound like an asshole if I say *'but you've gone through enough since your ex-boyfriend nearly gave you a concussion'*. Better switch gears. "...but I forgot."

"Ah. It's no big deal since you both came back in one piece. What happened?"

I take a minute to explain to her the gruesome scene we arrived at, and Samantha scrunches her face up. "Rosie? You said that was what the boy called her?"

"Mhm."

"Didn't Beelzebub have a girlfriend or whatever? Her name was Rosalia." Samantha finally mentions the name that was in my mind, and I quickly remember the girl's face and mannerisms.

"Oh, shoot, you're right. I forgot. I'm surprised you remembered. Isn't your memory usually awful?"

Samantha shrugs. "I saw the girl running around doing things now and then. Talked to her once or twice. The fact she was the killer doesn't surprise me, given her mental imbalance."

Cassiel jumps behind Samantha and wraps her arms around Sam's waist. "Heehee, you're a real psychologist, Sammy. What imbalance are you talking about, anyway?"

Samantha clasps Cass's hands in hers. "You didn't notice? She was head over heels for Beelzebub. All she ever did was talk about him, but I don't think he cared much about her, if at all."

"Explains a lot," I chime. "Kinda fucked-up she'd murder people over it, though. Why would she even do that?"

Helen's been quietly watching us, but she decides to offer her thoughts now. "Demons derive power from human souls. The Styx River takes the souls of dead humans and stores them, then the souls are given to demons the Emperors feel are deserving, but it's possible to bypass the approval process..." She trails off, and I swallow.

"What, by drinking from the source?"

"You guessed it." Helen looks away, a moment of trepidation in her eyes. "Horrible. Still, it's hard to call demonkind monsters, given my knowledge of angelkind. Bloodline discrimination, treating human converts like second-class citizens. Humans are either devoured by demons or turned into cannon fodder by angels."

Samantha is upset by the path the conversation has taken, though it's for a reason that surprises me. "Don't knock the angels. They gave humans a strong new body, with wings, and energy to keep them alive. They're the lesser of two evils."

"I suppose," Helen replies, keeping her voice neutral.

From across the yard, a man calls to me. "Hey, Hero! Jason!" I turn around to look, and spot King Cody Elshard traipsing across the grass toward our group. "I heard what happened. Your robot went berserk and cut down hundreds of my best soldiers."

I grimace, remembering that I was worried about what his reaction would be. "I guess 'sorry' doesn't cut it. I don't know what to say, Cody."

The king shakes his head and stops a dozen feet away, glancing at Helen with interest before turning back to me. "They were part of the forward guard and wore some of our best neo-armor. How am I supposed to replace them? What if another horde of demons attacks tomorrow?"

Samantha growls, deep in her throat, but Cody doesn't hear it. "They won't. The leader of the demons was Satan. He's fled to another... well, to the future, I suppose. Beelzebub is the new First Emperor of the demons."

King Elshard looks at her blankly for a few moments. "Beelzebub. The demon who walked among my palace staff? Is he a mole for us?"

I wince, knowing he won't like what he's about to hear. "No, he's just another one of my screw-ups. He despises humanity, but I believe we've taken care of him. We made him see the light during our last battle." *I think*, my mind whispers. Shut up!

Exhaling slowly, the king shakes his head. "A demon traitor was in our midst, my best men are cut down, and Humanity is backed into a corner, trapped in this city and a few outer worlds. Things look grim. Not to mention those green monsters you told me about."

"Green monsters?" I pause, trying to figure out what he's referring to. "The Kolvaxians?"

Helen interrupts before the king can reply. "What did you just say?" Her voice is ice.

"They're an alien species. I don't know much about them, other than they infect-"

She interrupts me again. "I know what the Kolvaxians are, but how could *you* possibly know of them? They've only appeared in one universe. We've been cautious about keeping them contained. I thought you said you weren't a Traveler?"

I still don't know what a Traveler is, but I try to keep my tone neutral, seeing a rising panic in her eyes. "I have yet to see them, but a reliable source has informed me that they exist in this galaxy. They pour in through a wormhole... or something. I don't know much about them beyond that."

Helen clenches and unclenches her fist, a nervous movement she isn't consciously performing. "No no no... they can't be here. It's impossible. Jason Alpha will shit fifty trillion bricks if he finds out." I've never heard her curse, so her sudden shift in tone makes me cringe. "The Kolvaxians have all but overtaken the K-universe. We had to deploy several clones many RTU's ago just to contain the spread of the infection. If they're spreading to other universes, it's a catastrophe on-par with, or exceeding, the Satan Protocol."

She's babbling about a lot of jargon I don't understand, but whatever has her spooked, it's basically the end of days.

"Okay. Well, can you contact Jason Alpha, have him come back? If he doesn't know about them, he should."

The elderly angel shakes her head slowly. "I didn't think I'd need my dilation transponder. He'll be back in a few RTU's, so we can just wait it out, but in the meantime, I need to find out the scope of the infection. How far have they spread? What are their numbers? Where do they originate from? What do-"

I raise my palm up to silence her. "I don't have the answers, Helen. Instead of asking me, we should find someone who knows. The Volgrim are battling them now, so they probably have the most updated information."

She nods and a look of relief floods her face. "Good, that's very good. The Volgrim alone are not nearly enough to stop the infection, nor to contain it, but the fact we're talking right now and the Labyrinth isn't overrun by them means the Volgrim must have the fighting capacity to slow them down and buy us time. Since they control the galaxy unopposed in this universe, that also means they've built up quite a reserve fleet."

Helen's relief is immediately washed away by Cassiel's quick, throwaway statement. "Oh. We accidentally wiped out a bunch of their reserves."

"Eh?" Helen blinks and wipes her forehead. "You uh... did what, now?"

"Not us, specifically... that Sentinel went berserk and tore a fleet that was attacking us to ribbons."

Several moments pass, and a smile freezes on Helen's face.

"Well, son of a biscuit."

Part 473c: The Turduckians

Tvoorik moans and whines as we travel the winding maze of the Labyrinth, stumbling against the wall every so often and letting out a pitiful yelp. I tried helping him along for a while until I realized what was *really* going on.

"Oh, the pain! The pain! My poor, aching head! I need medical! I need surgery!" Tvoorik wails again as we pass by a group of orcs, and all six of them glare at us before rolling their eyes and walking past. ' *Stupid halfwits*, ' one of them says. *Hey, don't lump me in with Tvoorik!*

Tvoorik mumbles and grumbles until we pass a Nymph, whose antenna glows enough to light the path in front of her. She holds a scroll in her hand and seems transfixed on whatever it says- right up until Tvoorik lets out his loudest yelp of pain yet. "Ahh, it's like a knife in my brain! A three-thousand degree knife plunged into my eyeballs! Make the pain stop, make it stop!"

She quickly lowers the scroll and picks up her pace and nearly runs past us, but this time I've had enough. Once she's out of earshot, I slug Tvoorik in the shoulder. "Will ya come off it already?! Seven Devils, every ding-damn demon and monster to the end of the nexus can hear your hollering and moaning!"

He rubs one of the fresh burn marks on his back. "B-b-but, Ylvusk, the crazy bitch lashed you too! How come you aren't in pain like me? I also have the seizures too! You can't understand how bad it hurts!"

"You need to knock it off with the whining. I know you're just trying to make everyone pity you, and it's getting on my nerves! You only moan like that whenever we pass someone! You're embarrassing me!" A vein bulges in my forehead as every muscle in my arm screams at me to slap the doofus. "Besides, ranting about 'green people this' and 'green people that' makes you look like more of a weirdo than the conspiracies did!"

Tvoorik's lip trembles and he lowers his head, then kicks a pebble at his feet. "Well, I mean, I can't help it. There's just so much pain..." He freezes for a moment, then quickly moves to cough into his fist. "Kah! In more ways than one. I'm connected to the demons in the Labyrinth like never before. All these thoughts, emotions, fear, and pain swirling in my head... If Diablo doesn't help me stop the pain, I'm gonna..." He quickly looks away and starts strolling down the hallway, leaving his ominous words hanging in the air.

I jump back into step and squint at him. "You'll do what? Off yourself? You've gotta be kidding."

He shakes his head, slowly. "I never thought I'd be an Oracle, let alone the first unique mutation. Those conspiracies I used to think about... they were right and wrong, but the scariest part is that the reality is worse than my imagination."

"What do you mean by 'worse'?"

A look of unease forms on Tvoorik's face. "Forget it. I shouldn't say. Oracles aren't allowed to disclose Labyrinth secrets to non-oracles lower than a Duke."

Well, that's a sorry excuse if I ever heard one. "C'mon, just tell me."

"If I can read the minds and know all that's going on in the Labyrinth, it's likely other Oracles can, too. I shouldn't."

We round the corner and the Blood Pits appear before us. I sigh at his stubbornness like I always do. "Fine, fine. Let's just find Diablo and see if he can help you."

Tvoorik touches his lip and stops. "Why don't you trust me?"

"Huh? What's with the loaded question?"

"I can read your mind," he mutters before turning back to the Regeneration Alcoves. "You think I'm lying and that I'm not bound by the rules of the Oracles. Hell, you don't even believe they exist."

My mood sours. "Okay, maybe a little bit. Can you blame me? I got whipped because of you. The burns still sting."

The fact Tvoorik's not whining and crying anymore tells me he really was just faking those screams for attention. One thing I've started noticing is that his vocabulary is improving quickly. He isn't quite as happy-go-lucky as he used to be, either. Hell, he's capable of critical thinking now when he wasn't before. I think he might be growing used to the pain of all the voices in his head.

Tvoorik nods as an imp strolls up to us, a wooden pad in his hand. "We're here to see Diablo."

The imp, barely two feet tall, is dwarfed by our presence. He glances at my menacing shadow-walker body and shivers before turning back to Tvoorik. "Nyeh! No visitors without an appointment! Lord Diablo has been placed in the custody of His Majesty, the First Emperor of Flames, Beelzebub!"

I raise an eyebrow. " *Lord* Diablo? So... it's true? Beelzebub took his power? He's no longer an Emperor?"

The imp stares at me like I'm the stupidest dummy in the whole Labyrinth. "Obviously! He's lucky to be a Lord, given how little energy he has left! At this point, I could probably kill him myself! Nyeh heh heh!" The imp lets out a shrill laugh that makes me cringe since it reminds me of not so many years ago before I'd earned my first mutation. "Anyway, you'll have to ask Emperor Beelzebub! Now begone, or I'll summon Hellga! She'll flatten you on your ass!"

"Are you threatening us, Master Jenoth?" Tvoorik suddenly kneels down and glares into the imp's face. "Yes, I know your name. I am the Seer, the most powerful of all the Oracles in the Labyrinth. I know every thought in your tiny brain, every worry, even trifles such as your lust for one of the Sirens in the Weeping Lake. Perhaps you should show us the courtesy of taking us to see Diablo, and I should show you respect by not revealing your bizarre taste in females to your fellow imps. I know well what imps do to their ostracized brethren."

The imp, apparently named Jenoth, stares for a few seconds, his eyes bulging. "W-well, when you... when you put it that way..."

"You're a smart one, Jenoth. Hop to it, then."

The imp swallows reflexively before forcing a smile and rubbing his hands together. "Y-yes! Come along! Jenoth will show you there!" He scurries away, all too eager to take us to Diablo and get out of our path.

I glance at Tvoorik, a newfound realization of his abilities. Of course, he can probably read the awe in my eyes... along with the fear. "How did you think of that so quickly?"

A shrug. "My mental acuity is sharpening at an accelerating rate. Head still hurts, but the pain is suddenly more bearable."

Mental acuity. The Tvoorik I know would never say words like that. He's just not that sharp.

Minutes crawl by as the imp beckons repeatedly. "Come on, demons. It's a little way to go, yet! Jenoth will show you the way."

I gaze around at the sick and injured demons stumbling and kneeling, some with limbs missing, others who stare vacantly forward, as if they've seen one of the many Ghosts in the Labyrinth. However, I quickly realize that what I see is only the surface level, while Tvoorik gazes below the surface.

"That one, Griknash, lost a mate." He subtly points out an orc as we pass by the monster. "Humans killed her with one of their 'boomsticks.' They raided an Orc Nursery. Female orcs care for the young; they don't fight battles. Since orcs bond for life, his heart was torn to shreds by her death."

"Heart?" I echo Tvoorik's words. "I thought Orcs were just dumb killing machines."

Tvoorik shakes his head. "That's what most demons picture when they think of orcs, including myself until I became a Seer. Griknash was shamed, along with his fellow tribe members, despite not being at fault for the humans attacking the nursery. He was on a raid, fighting a rival tribe during the pillage. To restore his honor, he launched a sneak attack on those who killed his mate, but he failed, and they got away. He lost his right eye in the ambush, and now he has nothing left. No honor, no mate, no spawn, and half the vision compared to what he had."

I eye Tvoorik carefully as he says this. "Yeah? You don't look very shaken up about it."

"I'm not. It has nothing to do with me. Just an observation."

We make our way past a group of goblins cackling about something, but Tvoorik aims his eyes up ahead. "Diablo's up there, in that walled-off room. The one with the guards at the entrance. He's in pain, but otherwise mobile. His thoughts are a scattered mess. Hard to pick anything specific out."

"Maybe he's still frightened by the ass-whipping Beelzebub gave him. Right, Tvoorik?" I flash a smile at him, but he ignores me.

As we approach the Lord-level guards, neither of whom are wearing any armor or holding any weapons, one of them holds his palm up. "Hold. Identify yourself. Only authorized visitors may see Lord Diablo."

Tvoorik squints at the demon as if trying to focus his mind for a moment. The fellow's slicked-back hair, black like most demons, and ruby-red skin, are nothing special, but the way he holds himself is like that of nobility, groomed for success. He appears to take pride in his post guarding the former Third Emperor, but that's all I can figure out on a surface level. The padded suit makes him look more intimidating than he probably is, but I wouldn't fight a Lord unless my life depended on it.

"Beelzebub sent us. The password is 'The Fire Lily blooms twice a year.' I believe that will suffice."

The guard immediately nods. "Ah, sorry for questioning you, sir. Orders are orders. Step right in."

"I will. Thank you." Tvoorik smoothes his robes and acts bored, as though this is nothing out of the ordinary for him. *When did he become such a good actor?*

The guard quickly pulls out a key and unlocks the door. Tvoorik pretends he's someone influential, and barely nods at the Lord. Before we can step inside, the Lord crinkles his nose.

"Sorry to be a bother sir, but the Shadow-walker has to stay outside. We're worried about potential... assassination threats." He winces as if expecting a rebuke, but Tvoorik just nods.

"I understand. I'll let Emperor Beelzebub know you said that."

"What?" The guard pales and looks at his friend. "W-what do you mean by that?"

"I'll let him know you said I couldn't bring my personal guard. What was your name, by the way?"

"Uhh..." The demon swallows audibly. "It's Sir... Sir... you know what? It's fine. Go on in, you both look trustworthy."

"That's very kind of you. Come along, Ylvusk."

I nod at him, then glance back, looking for the imp. He must have vanished when I wasn't paying attention. Slippery little dick.

A few moments later, the giant door creaks shut behind us, leaving us standing in a narrow hallway. A wood floor and walls greet us, standing out compared to the Labyrinth I know. A few candles are lit, here and there, but it's hard to see, or at least it would be, were I not a Shadow-walker.

With all the darkness around, I stretch out my consciousness and detect Diablo moving in an adjacent room, but Tvoorik starts moving toward it anyway.

"Looks like Bael's here too. I wonder why," I say.

"We'll soon find out," Tvoorik says, his voice nearly a whisper.

Tvoorik pushes the door to the next room open, and a stench hits me that nearly knocks me off my feet. Like a wild dog, my eyes convulse and narrow in on Bael, his body covered in dried blood. It's turned brown by this point, but he hasn't a care in the world. He lounges on a couch, laying on his side and watching as Diablo paces back and forth, whose body is covered in blood as well, but under his robes. The room is nearly barren, save a table, some chairs, and a mess of crumpled up papers tossed to the side. Both of them notice us almost immediately, but neither smile and greet us like they usually would.

Diablo barely pays attention to me but instead squints at Tvoorik. "Who're you, and why'd you bring the backup? Need protection? Or maybe you're here to give me more excuses."

Tvoorik squints again, but this time, some of the confidence in his voice from earlier is missing. "Ehh, you probably don't recognize me. He's Ylvusk, and I'm Tvoorik. I evolved."

Diablo pauses his pacing to glare at us. "That's nice. I don't care. Did Beelzebub send you?"

A moment passes before Tvoorik responds, and he's still squinting like he's trying to concentrate, but veins bulge on his forehead. Whatever he's trying to do, he isn't having much success. "No. I came here to ask you a few questions. I evolved into a unique form of Oracle, and I'm having major issues focusing. My head feels as if it's going to explode."

For the second time today, the two of us are stared at like we're the biggest idiots of all time. Bael chuckles. "Kukuku, at least they came here for somethin' important, right Deebs?"

"Shut up." Diablo rubs his forehead. "The Labyrinth hangs on the brink of destruction, and you pester me about a migraine?"

Evidently, Tvoorik gives up trying to concentrate, since he pulls back and mirrors Diablo's movements by rubbing his own forehead. "Brink of destruction? Did I miss the memo?"

"Yes. You did." The former Third Emperor resumes his pacing and throws his hands in the air. "I needed a reply two days ago! Two days! The Volgrim are probably already dead. The monsters killed them. That Beelzebub is just worthless. I thought he might accomplish something, but he's so fixated on the humans he's missing the bigger picture!"

"Calm down, Deebs. You ain't gonna fix anything by grumbling all the time. Bad for your heart, too." Bael sticks his finger in his nose and pulls it back, revealing something disgusting enough that I immediately look away. A sickening slurping noise from his side of the room makes my stomach churn. "Everyone knows zombies are weak to fire. Once he puts it all together, those alien freaks won't stand a chance. Relax."

"I can't relax! I gave him my power so that I could, but I can't!" Diablo hisses under his breath. "Stupid, stupid moron."

I decide to butt in. "What do you mean by 'zombies' and 'aliens'? Are you talking about the Volgrim?"

"The Volgrim are history. Probably dead." Diablo pivots on his heel, marches over to the table and grabs a small gadget, not unlike something I'd expect the humans to use. He presses the screen, and a bunch of words appear, though I can't read any of them from my angle. "They sent me a coded communication through my holopad. I can barely work the damn thing, but the SOS said they were under attack and needed assistance from the demons immediately." He exhales slowly. "The Volgrim have never asked for help from our kind. Either because of pride or trust issues, they refused even when I offered. If they needed our assistance, the situation was dire."

"It's probably nothing," Bael muses. "Even if it was, the Volgrim always lord their authority. I don't give a crap if they get killed. Serves 'em right."

Tvoorik slowly licks his lips. "Better the devil you know than the devil you don't. The ones who attacked the Volgrim might be-

"They are." Diablo cuts Tvoorik off, his voice cold. "Kolvaxians. The Volgrim were delivering irregular reports to me that hinted the Kolvaxians were gaining more and more control of the galaxy. The last report I received said that Jason Hiro, along with that Sentinel of his, destroyed a large portion of the Volgrim reserve fleets. Then I received the S.O.S. requesting assistance..." Diablo shakes his head. "It's been two days. Beelzebub must be ignoring the messengers I sent him, thinking he's too high and mighty to listen to what I have to say."

My friend is uncertain of what to say, but after a few seconds, he speaks up. "You shouldn't have lost to Beelzebub if that were the case."

"Huh? I didn't lose. I gave him my energy freely." Diablo rolls his eyes. "Is that what the rumors say; that he defeated me in combat, or something silly like that? Even missing half of my shoulder, fighting Beelzebub would be like dropping an Orc on an Imp."

"It's not exactly a rumor..." Tvoorik says, trailing off. "He announced it to the Lord and Dukes. He said he crushed you and Bael in combat."

A moment passes, and I glance over at Bael to see a bone-chilling smile on his face. "He did, huh? That's cute. I'll have to ask him about that, next time I see him."

"Now's not the time, Bael. Anyway, if you two are here, maybe you can do something to help. Whatever those Kolvaxians are, they're a threat that terrifies the Volgrim. If the leaders of Demon-kind won't take action, perhaps the humans will. You should contact the Hero and see if he can assist the Volgrim, assuming it isn't already too late."

"That sounds reasonable," Tvoorik responds quickly, before freezing up. "Wait- no. What are you saying? You want us to talk to humans? Have you gone mad?!"

Diablo holds his palms up and turns to face us. "Calm down. The Hero isn't all that bad. I beat the crap out of him before Belial returned the favor. We had a quick chat before that, and he's been taking marked steps to improve relations between demons and humans." The giant demon sighs. "I wish I'd noticed sooner. It was only after I gave Beelzebub my energy in a moment of weakness that I finally had the time to sit back and relax. Then I realized my mistake."

Bael snickers. "Pft, and I always thought you were the smart Emperor."

"Smarter than you," Diablo says, as he steps forth and rests his hand on Tvoorik's shoulder. "The humans are terrible in many ways, but so are demons. So are the Volgrim. It doesn't mean

we can't come to an agreement. If you find and warn Jason Hiro, he might be able to save us in time."

Tvoorik glances at me. "What do you think? Never mind, I already know."

"Funny."

He pulls Diablo's hand off. "I thought you hated being an Emperor, yet here you are, trying to lead again. Were you secretly power-hungry all along?"

"No. It was never about my desire to lead, but the futility in trying. I was third on the food chain. The First Emperor always loomed in the background, and angering him was the last thing I wanted to do. Belial was never an issue, not until recently, but the monumental difference in power between myself and the First made me not care about changing the status quo."

"Self preservation," Tvoorik mutters. "What makes you think things will change now? The First may override you anyway."

"I expect he will, but it's Beelzebub who takes the fall now, and not myself. Besides, that's why you need to warn the humans. If the First decides to ignore the Kolvaxians, the humans will be the only thing stopping the Labyrinth from being destroyed."

"And if they decide to kill the messenger..." My friend hisses nervously. "You know Ylvusk and I killed a bunch of humans in our last raid, right? That's why I became a Seer."

Diablo laughs. "Hah! All demons look the same to a human. Besides, you're an Oracle. You can read minds. I'm certain you'll be able to convince them."

Tvoorik rubs his forehead again. "Only if I can stop this damn migraine. Don't you know any tricks? Anything at all?"

"Obviously." Diablo grunts, then reaches up and presses a thumb to Tvoorik's forehead. "I was an Oracle for several years, you know. So was Satan, but Belial skipped that evolution and mutated into a different branch. Your migraine and torrent of thoughts are due to your inability to focus the mental energy properly. It's a hurricane in your mind, but you need to soothe it, and turn it into a focused marble that moves from place to place." He laughs. "Haha, and maybe you'll have better luck trying to read my mind. Oracles can't read the minds of past or present Oracles. Still, it's funny to feel you trying."

With a chuckle, Tvoorik closes his eyes and strains. "Sorry. I didn't mean to be rude, Emperor Diab-

"Lord, not Emperor. The old title doesn't fit my position anymore. Now shut up and focus your mana at the point where my thumb is. Breathe. Relax. Do this several times. You'll be able

to stop the pain that way."

While those two do their exercises, I saunter over to Bael. He barely even looks at me. "What?"

"That's what I want to ask you. Aren't you still a Duke? Why are you even here? You could easily beat the crap out of the Lords out front. You don't have to stay here."

The giant demon smirks. "Like I give a shit. I work for Diablo, not that snot-nosed runt. Even with Diablo's power, one glance from me 'n he took off running. Besides, Diablo's right. I just wanna lay around and be lazy. Getting the shit kicked out of me ain't fun, ya know?"

"I guess. What's up with the blood?" I gesture at the smelly residue covering his body, and Bael shrugs.

"We have to leave it on, for a while. Hellga's rules. It's pretty calming, actually. You should try out the pits sometime. Tastes great, too."

"I'll take your word on it. I hope someone cleaned the blood out after you were done with it."

Bael raises his middle finger to me. "Up yours. You're just jealous of my good looks, stinky."

Diablo and Tvoorik finish up in the corner, so I roll my eyes at Bael. "Nice projection, Duke of Chains. I'll be seeing you around."

"I hope not."

Tvoorik nods at me as I walk over. "Diablo's right! That worked swell, buddy!"

"Good to hear." I watch as he chats with Diablo for a few minutes, and a thought occurs to me. *His speech has become less sophisticated all of a sudden. The result of learning to control his abilities?*

"You're the best, Diablo! I'll make sure 'n let that Jasper fellow know about the Turduckians."

Diablo's eye twitches. " *Jason. Kolvaxians.* Lucifer's Ghost, maybe I helped you out a little *too* much. Get moving; time's running short."

"Caaaan do!" Tvoorik nudges me. "C'mon pal, let's bust this joint."

"Yup."

As we stroll out the front door, Tvoorik smiles jovially at the guard from before, whose body shakes as we walk past. "You're doin' a great job! I'll make sure Beelzebub knows how helpful you were!"

The demon Lord calms down noticeably. "Really? Oh, I thank you very much for your kindness!"

Once we're out of earshot, Tvoorik nudges me. "I didn't wanna embarrass him, but that guard had the hots for you. Maybe it ain't a girl you need."

"Shut up, Tvoorik."

I smile, in spite of myself. At least he's the same as he's always been. I couldn't stand to lose him.

Part 474c: Axis Mundi

Samantha and I follow Helen and Cassiel as the older woman walks around Axis Mundi, a cheekily named dimension that the hundred or so remaining angels live in. She points out each angel we come across and has Cassiel shake their hands. "This man is Roger, he used to be an architect before he died, and this pretty lady over here is Petra, she was a diplomat, and over here is..."

Cassiel, bless her heart, smiles and says hello to each new angel, though it's apparent to everyone besides Helen that she hasn't a chance of remembering all their names. While she introduces herself, Samantha and I gaze around at the architecture. It's a self-contained bubble dimension, completely flat, and stretches out into the distance for miles around. Every angel has a mansion they live in, and each one has a distinct style. Some of them are Japanese inspired, others remind me of Roman architecture, and there are tons of space-age buildings I don't recognize at all. As Helen explained earlier, the angels moved here so the demons and Volgrim wouldn't find them, and they're mostly cut off from the outside universe.

Given that angels can only survive so long off their energy, I wasn't sure how they survived all this time, but it turns out Jason Alpha gave them a single infusion of all of his energy at once several million years ago, and that alone has given them more than enough. They haven't used even half of it over that period, and he regenerated it after one night of sleep anyway. Wordsmiths are overpowered.

Samantha slows to a stop, allowing Cassiel and Helen to keep walking, but she lightly pinches my long sleeves. "Hey, Jason. All the angels are staring at me."

I glance at her ridiculously exposed outfit, then to the pure white robes most of them are wearing, except for one angel who's wearing Roman legionnaire armor. Apparently, he's the odd one of the bunch, since he was an avid Renaissance Faire attendee and loves to dress up, even after his death. At least the angel wings kinda make him look like a Valkyrie.

"I can't imagine why, Samantha," I snort sarcastically, "it's probably been a long time since they saw someone openly baring that much skin."

"That's not it," she says, and her tail jerks around like a worried dog's. Occasionally it pauses and twitches. "It's because I'm a demon. Everyone smiles at me, but I think they're disguising their hatred."

"Possibly. As Helen said, Satan and millions of demons attacked and killed the angels during their final war, only sparing these remaining stragglers after killing off the purebloods and

forcing Gabriel to sacrifice himself. Considering you're Satan's ex-girlfriend..."

Samantha bows her head. "I know. I just let him do it. I didn't know he planned such an awful act, but by the time I found out, it was far too late."

"It's not your fault. Satan seems like..." I pause, realizing that badmouthing someone she once loved will probably twist up her insides. "...he was... an *interesting* fellow."

"He was a piece of shit. I don't know why I stuck with him as long as I did, nor what I saw in him." Samantha states her opinion bluntly, rendering me speechless. "Maybe I was just young and naive. I lost that excuse after four thousand years of his plotting and scheming, though. Maybe I assumed that as long as he won, it was proof that his ideals were correct."

I reach around her back and grip her shoulder, pulling her close to me. "Everyone makes mistakes. You just have to accept them and try to move on."

Sam leans her head back against my arm. "I don't think I deserve that though, Jason. These angels became refugees because I never stood up to Satan. I was the second most powerful of the demons, and for years I was the only one who had the power to stand up to him, but I didn't. Directly or indirectly, it's my fault they're in this situation."

"Yeah, well, Jason Alpha failed to defeat the demons, so he's at fault too." I stop talking for a moment to notice the irony of criticizing another version of myself. What if I had lived his life? Wouldn't I have made the same mistakes? "Hell, time travel can't solve all the issues of the multiverse, so I don't think you should feel responsible for Satan's shitty decisions."

"I guess," Samantha mutters noncommittally.

Before I can question her about why she keeps beating herself up, Cassiel and Helen appear before us, having wandered back after noticing we disappeared. "Ooh, what are you two up to?" Cassiel winks and smiles, but it deflates when she sees the look on Samantha's face. "Oh."

"It's not a big deal," I say, "Sam just feels a little uncomfortable because of how all the angels are staring at her."

Helen nods. "Well, your choice of clothing certainly stands out. If you think it's because you're a demon and they hate you, I'd say that's quite inaccurate." Apparently, the old woman is more perceptive than she lets on.

"Huh?" Samantha pulls her head back and gazes at Helen quizzically. "Why would that be inaccurate?"

"It's war, sweetheart. Bad things happen. People die. All of the angels here were humans, turned back into angels. Heaven, as great as it might seem, was bland, boring, and inescapable. Human converts were expected to fight on the frontlines and die first, should war break out.

Purebloods treated half-bloods as their inferiors, even if they did smile and act pleasantly to our faces. Only one or two purebloods were considered good and honest, but compared to the comfortable existences we lead now, Heaven was a torturous place." Helen taps her lip. "I lived in Heaven for over fifty years before the man you know as Jason Alpha set me free. I was able to speak with my husband again, and I even got to live aboard a spaceship. It was great fun! However, other converts were not as lucky as me."

Samantha eyes the older woman carefully. "Are you saying many of the angels here are *glad* that Satan nearly wiped out their brethren?"

"Not glad, but also not angry. Death is a regretful thing. Freedom from bondage is a joyous thing. I'd say most are happy for the change in scenery, sad for the price we paid. Several of the converts here lived in Heaven for two thousand years, having been reformed during the generation after Michael's sacrifice. They made many, many friends over those years, only to have the overwhelming majority wiped away in an instant. Tens of millions of years can dull the heartbreak, however. I would say most are content with how things have ended up, and that's that."

"I see." For the first time today, Samantha smiles faintly. "I'm glad some good came of the war, however little it may be."

"In times of darkness, a glimpse of light can shine like the midday sun. The fact everyone gets to meet an angel the demons captured all this time, yet who also survived, has bolstered their morale dramatically. Even Jeremiah is smiling, and he's always a grumpy old grouch!" She points over at an angel whose boyish figure makes him look twelve years old. He dribbles a basketball in a nearby court and rolls his eyes when he sees us staring. Nobody else is playing, but he's having fun shooting some hoops.

"Grumpy... old man?" Samantha's face twists in disbelief. "He looks like a kid."

"He was just a boy living in the Roman Empire when a bunch of barbarians tore him to pieces. Took him two days to die. Angels don't usually change appearance, no matter how much time passes. He's much older than me!" Helen laughs. "Of course, so are you, but age is arbitrary after a certain point. We call him 'grumpy old man' just to rile him up. If you play along with the joke, it's much funnier."

Samantha chuckles. "Heh, I see your point." She and I both ignore the bit about the kid being torn to pieces since it's too awful to imagine. "Maybe I should say hi to some of the angels here. I'm probably just a little shy."

Cassiel's wings twitch, and she quickly steps forward and yanks Samantha away from me, giving her a big hug. "Oh, you! You're the least shy girl I know!"

"Jeez, Cass! You're embarrassing me!" Samantha protests weakly, but she doesn't actually mind.

Minutes pass. Soon we arrive at a building Helen dubs the 'Administrative Facility'. If there is a Creator of this universe, he's *terrible* at naming things. "I have a few friends among the demons; ones who know of the Angels' existence but keep silent, never telling anyone about us. They feed me gossip and tales of what's going on, but they aren't very high up. I heard rumors that the humans were staging a comeback and it was causing the Emperors many problems, but I never imagined the cause would be another Jason."

We make our way up the chiseled marble steps, and I marvel at how it looks like a courthouse from the time period I originated. Ten giant pillars lead up to an overhang above the entrance, and a plaque affixed to the protrusion reads ' *In Jason We Trust* '.

Cute.

Helen notices where my gaze is directed. "Just to be clear, we put that up, not Jason Alpha. He's fairly humble, despite his power. Alpha thought it was a little tacky."

Well, that's another thing we share in common.

I decide to ask the question on my mind. "Why the name 'Jason Alpha' anyway? If he's so humble, the name kinda says the opposite."

"The clone naming system was initially convoluted and changed several times. We needed a direct way to identify the primary Seed for each Wordsmith, so he came up with the Term 'alpha' since it's the first letter in the Ancient Greek alphabet. Likewise, Satan Prime is considered the progenitor of his clones."

"If he's the original Jason, then what happens if he dies? Do the clones die as well?"

Helen shrugs noncommittally. "Nobody knows. We won't know unless it happens, and the goal is to obviously make sure it doesn't. I'm 99% sure they won't, just based on events involving other clones, but it's tough to say. Have you ever cloned yourself before?"

Several memories bubble up. "Yes."

A moment of awkward silence follows, and Cassiel clears her throat. "So, um, Helen! Why are we coming here anyway?"

"To find out if anyone has intercepted news about the Volgrim. If their fleet can't hold off the Kolvaxians, we'll need to know."

"Why not just pop over to the Volgrim headquarters and say hello?" I ask. "You think they'll attack us on site or something?"

"One does not simply walk into the Council of Elders," Helen replies. "Especially not you. While they likely know of your Wordsmithing thanks to communications with the demons, no Volgrim is aware of the past or its history with relation to Jason Alpha."

"I don't see why that's a problem."

She sighs. "The Volgrim are a proud race. The reason Jason Alpha allowed them to eventually rule the galaxy outside of the Labyrinth is because he saw a certain quality in them; one of fairness. They treat subordinates equally, including the demons and humans. The Energy Wars were caused entirely by misunderstandings, not because they hated humans. Well, not at first. To be fair, destroying their homeworld may have annoyed them, just a teensy bit!" Helen smirks. "Anyway, while they are fair, we believe this is only due to them forgetting the cause of their homeworld's destruction."

I try not to look too bored. "Uh huh. And what's that?"

"Jason Alpha, of course. He destroyed Volgarius. Eradicated the entire star system, and killed trillions of Volgrim in an instant. They only managed to escape thanks to a space station several lightyears away that we didn't know about."

My jaw drops. "What? He did that? That's... dark. Genocidal. Evil, even." My hands shake slightly as another thought enters my mind. *He and I are very similar. Would I commit genocide as well? Is that something I'm capable of?*

Samantha butts in. "Hold on, how did he destroy the planet? I'm... I'm having memories come back to me, all of a sudden."

Helen shakes her head slowly. "He created a meteor made entirely of iron, then reinforced it with Wordsmithing beyond any natural limits, and flung it at warp speed toward their planet. The resulting catastrophe obliterated the planet, the star, and every other speck of matter in the system."

A minute passes as Samantha and I gaze at each other, then Cassiel, then back to Helen, trying to wrap our mind around the idea. Samantha is the one to break the silence. "Th-the... the Kolvaxians... Jason, don't you remember? Beatrix and Ben Brown... they told us that the Kolvaxians came pouring through a wormhole- a tear in space."

Cassiel's eyes widen. "The one at Volgarius Prime?! Then, doesn't that mean Jason Alpha created the tear?"

Helen opens her mouth to speak, thinks better of it, closes it, then opens it again. "Ah-that's... are you certain? I suppose that would explain how the Kolvaxians arrived. In fact, that's

the most disturbing news I've heard in years. Alpha will be furious when he learns this news... mostly at himself."

"Yeah. He should be," Samantha says, tossing her hair back. "He not only committed genocide, he tore a goddamn hole in space with his stunt. Monsters are invading because of his actions."

I know it isn't logical, but Samantha's words stab right into my heart. *That could be me she's talking about*, my brain whispers. *You can't say for sure you'd never do the same thing were you in his shoes.*

"The pieces are falling into place," Helen grumbles. "And now I think I see how the Kolvaxians arrived here. Saint Peter bless my soul, I think they're pouring in from the K universe."

"Can I seal the wormhole?" I offer, but Helen shrugs.

"Maybe. The problem is that you might be a Wordsmith, but the Kolvaxians are unlike anything you've ever faced. There are Jasons with hundreds of thousands of battles against Kolvaxians who come up short sometimes. Tracking them is difficult, their bodies emit trace amounts of anti-energy, and they adapt to new tactics remarkably fast. To close the hole, you'd have to go there in person. If this hole is the gateway from which they originate, they will guard it fiercely. Plus, I don't know if Wordsmithing or Thoughtsmithing can seal a wormhole. It might be impossible, in which case you'd be..."

Helen trails off, and her skin pales. "You know, there's something about the Kolvaxians that should give you sleepless nights, young Wordsmith."

I'm already a little bit scared, but I keep my expression neutral. "Yeah?"

"They convert humans, demons, Volgrim, anything they come into contact with into other Kolvaxians. We've fought them for ages, and still barely know anything about them, but what we do know is that they're a hivemind. They absorb the knowledge of each individual and add it to their collective. We've gone to great lengths to ensure they never ever get their hands on a Wordsmith. It might spell the end of the Multiverse if they did."

"What, like, they could use Wordsmithing if they took over Jason?" Cassiel's expression contorts into horror. "That's awful! You can't take a risk like that!"

"Yeah," Samantha chimes in. "Even if you knew for sure you could seal the tear, the Kolvaxians might transform you into one of them, and they'd become unstoppable."

Before I can allay their concerns, a buzzing sound rumbles in my ear, transmitting to my mind. The telepathic earrings, apparently. Good thing I built a connector node inside this place

when I arrived.

Samantha and Cassiel raise their hands to their ears simultaneously, almost like they're answering a phone. Helen gives us a confused look, but I ignore her and answer the 'call.'

This is Jason. Is someone trying to use this channel?

Ben's voice appears in my mind. *You still hanging out with the angels?*

Yes. Why?

Two demons just appeared at our doorstep. They declared they were friendly and demanded they speak to you. Said it was a message from Diablo.

Samantha raises an eyebrow and glances at me. "The heck would Diablo want?"

"Dunno, Sam."

Ben, detain and restrain them. I'm a little busy right now. I'll talk with them later.

For a moment, I think he's shut off the feed without answering, but his voice appears in my mind, a hint of worry in it. *They say it's about the Kolvaxians. I pressed them for an answer, and they said something about an S.O.S. signal from the Volgrim.*

"Oh," I say out loud. "In that case, tell them I'll be right there." I pause, realizing Ben can't hear me talk out loud. *Tell them I'll be right there.*

"Helen, two demons just appeared at our doorstep. They have information about the Kolvaxians."

Helen's eyes bulge. "Really? Well, get down there, then- no, actually, take me with you. I want to hear what they have to say."

"I assumed you would." I pause, glancing inside the Administration building. "Maybe we should finish this first."

"Most demons don't know about Kolvaxians," Samantha says. "If two random ones appear saying Diablo sent them, I'm certain they aren't lying. Their information is probably, no offense to Helen, more up to date than anything here."

Helen rolls her eyes. "Sad, but true. My spies among the demons are fairly unreliable. If those demons don't give us anything useful, we can come back."

"I'll make it quick," I remark, as I aim my mind at the ground. " **Waypoint.** Now we can return here once we're done. **Return.** "

The four of us vanish and reappear inside the heart of Hero City, and I activate my earpiece. *Ben, where are you holding them?*

* * *

A minute later, I teleport again, this time taking us to the border of the city, just inside the portal to the Labyrinth. Ben is just putting anti-energy cuffs onto the demons, both of whom look a little sullen. Immediately, I identify a Shadow-walker, the scummiest of demons, and an odd one dressed in grey robes, with a gold brooch clasped onto his clothes just under his throat. He looks somewhat important and carries an air of authority about him.

Perhaps he's the leader of these two. The information might be reliable!

The robed one spots me and nudges his companion. "Ylvusk! Looky! It's the Hero guy! I told you he exists!!!"

His friend, the shadow-walker sighs, his voice a deep growl. "I thought you said he *didn't* exist, nutcase."

"Same thing! You're always getting hung up on the icky-sticky details!"

It's at this moment I realize something significant.

These idiots are going to be no help at all.

Part 475c: Portal

The demon with the robes, Tvoorik, smiles giddily as his eyes scan me up and down. "You're a huge fella! And that skin makes you look like a shadow-walker variant!"

All around us, people mill around in the outpost, some of them glancing warily at the demons before spotting Cassiel and going back to their business. She and Helen have the effect of calming anyone down who are worried about terrible things happening. I keep thinking back to all the times people have been ecstatic when they see Cassiel and how they always prostrate themselves before her, calling her the 'Divine Mother.' I'm just glad she fits in, now.

Ben lightly kicks Tvoorik in the rump. "Hey now! Don't go calling Jason a shadow-walker! That's insulting!"

The other demon, a shadow-walker himself, glares at Ben. "No, you're insulting. What are you, a shadow-human?"

"Clever," Ben hisses.

"Calm down, boys." Samantha puts her foot down, silencing the three of them before turning to Tvoorik. "Why did you say Diablo sent you? What did you mean by that?"

Tvoorik's smile fades. "Oh, well, see, there's a bunch of aliens that are attacking the Volgrim. He found out because they sent their SOS to his gadget doohickey thing." Tvoorik turns to me. "Kinda like that watch of yours. It has the screen that lights up."

Samantha crosses her arms. "I'm surprised Diablo would use anything involving technology. I'm terrible with that stuff, but he makes me look like a genius."

"Maybe he's been practicing," I offer helpfully. "So if the Kolvaxians are attacking, why would Diablo want us to know? We'll certainly try to stop them, but surely the demons are capable of intervening."

The shadow-walker coughs. "Have you seen the new Second Emperor? Beelzebub single-mindedly focuses on eliminating the humans. According to Diablo, he barely even knows who the Volgrim are."

"Beelzebub is the First Emperor now," Samantha says, correcting him. "The First Emperor is gone."

"Gone?!" Tvoorik twitches in surprise. "How- when- why?! Did he die? Did you guys kill him?"

"No, he fled. It's a long story, but we sent him packing. With the First Emperor gone, that leaves Beelzebub as the new first." Samantha adjusts the strap on her bra. "Oh, and the First Emperor was Satan. You probably didn't know that, but you do now."

"S-Satan." Tvoorik echoes the word before suddenly jerking his hand out and squeezing the other demon's shoulder. "It's just like I said." He hisses the words out.

"Okay, big deal, you got one prediction right. Call me back when you get better than a five percent success rate," Ylvusk says, before pulling away from his friend's grasp. "Anyway, we've done our part. We told you what Diablo wanted us to say. What now? You gonna kill us or something?"

"Uhh..." I draw the word out, unsure how to respond. "I mean, you're technically our enemy, but you don't seem evil. I think we can let you go."

"Wait." Ben steps between the demons and me and his faceplate opens. "Centurion analyzed their genetic markers compared to blood found at the scene of the recent attack on this outpost. The shadow-walker was one of the two demons who attacked our men and women. I'm not letting them go."

"The suit can do that? How?"

Ben nods at me. "Detective Mode. It's a special system that analyzes crime scenes."

"Handy," I mutter, as I carefully push him aside. "Tvoorik, Ylvusk, is what he said true? Did one or both of you attack our command posts?"

Ylvusk keeps his expression neutral, but Tvoorik cringes visibly. "Err, well, that is..."

Great. They're guilty. "I suppose that answers my question. You'll both have to be put on trial for your crimes, since we have courts for humans and demons. I should thank you for the information, but now it kinda leaves a sour taste in my mouth."

Samantha still stands with her arms crossed, watching our exchange, but now she butts in. "Hold on, Jason. Before we send them off, I need to know... Tvoorik, what species are you? You look like a Unique Mutation of demon."

The robed demon sheepishly itches the back of his head. "Oh... ah, yeah. I'm a Seer. It's an advanced form of an Oracle."

"A Seer," Samantha repeats what he said, a puzzled expression on her face. "How did you not know Satan was the First Emperor? Every Oracle should have noticed his appearance at the same time."

"It's a new muta-" Tvoorik pauses, and suddenly covers his mouth, a guilty look frozen on his face.

"That's what I thought. You killed those people while they were off-duty, then you used their souls to mutate." Samantha turns back to me. "Throwing him in prison is a waste. What he did was despicable, but I think we can use him."

"Use me? W-what do you mean by that?!" Tvoorik slips the words out but backs down as Samantha shoots a hot glare at him.

"Cut the indignation. I may not officially be a Demon Emperor anymore, but I'm technically powerful enough to beat the crap out of Beelzebub without Jason's help. I can pull rank if you wish."

"Yes, ma'am." Tvoorik bows his head, unable to respond.

Helen and Ben share a glance. She speaks. "I don't know what you're thinking, Belial, but we don't need a backstabbing demon. Worse, we're wasting time. If these two have told the truth, the Volgrim are in grave danger. We need to leave now."

"We don't know where the Kolvaxians will attack, nor what we'll run into when we get there," Samantha says, before turning back to Tvoorik. "If you're a unique Oracle, what does that entail? Any special abilities?"

Tvoorik nods slowly. "Well, I think I have all the usual stuff... like seeing and knowing all. I have a unique ability to see into the future, as well."

"The future?" This time it's me who speaks. "How? That seems implausible."

Ylvusk, the shadow-walker, narrows his eyes at me. "You can create objects with your mind, summon weapons out of thin air, and destroy whole planets with your abilities. Why would foresight sound odd to you?"

"Never mind." He makes a good point, so I quickly concede. No point arguing when you've already lost.

The Seer clears his throat. "Based on my visions, I bet the Trollboxians are attacking the Volgrim homeworld."

"Kolvaxians," Ben says, correcting Tvoorik. "And call me a skeptic, but I can't see the Kolvaxians arriving at the Volgrim homeworld. They were nowhere near it, last I heard."

"How long ago was that?" I ask.

"Well, admittedly it was several months ago."

"Oh."

Helen rubs her elbow. "Well, if it's the Volgrim homeworld the Kolvaxians are going to show up at, you'll be useless for getting there, Jason. That is, unless you've been there before."

"I haven't."

She sighs. "That's what I expected. Luckily, Alpha built an emergency device just for this purpose. We can jump straight to Melkin from the portal machine in Axis Mundi. It has several designated exit points at key locations across the galaxy."

Melkin, apparently, is the name of the new Volgrim homeworld. "That's convenient. And dangerous. Why would you have a portal that leads directly to an enemy homeworld? Isn't that a bit of a death-wish?"

Helen shakes her head. "It's a one-way device. It opens a hole directly from Axis Mundi to one of the other designated points, but it doesn't require a machine at the target location, and it can't be opened from the other side. Less risky than you'd think."

Samantha's tail swings around and pokes me in the back. "Jason, it's dangerous for another reason, as well. What if the Kolvaxians have taken over the planet? If we show up there, it'll be the same as if you teleported into the heart of their territory to seal the wormhole."

"She's right," Ben says, a cautious tone in his voice. "I don't think you should go there. Better to go by spaceship and take a little more time than rush into a death-trap."

"No worries!" Tvoorik yells, making everyone flinch in surprise. "I haven't had any visions of the immediate future where Jasper dies, so it's all good! We're totally fine!"

A silence falls over us. Cassiel squirms. "That's, um, comforting... Tvoorik."

"Thanks!" he says, ignoring the fact that nobody believes him.

A few minutes of deliberation pass as we discuss what the best method is for traveling there. Unfortunately, the Volgrim are the official resistance against the Kolvaxian invasion, so taking our time isn't possible. If they're wiped out, the chances of the galaxy surviving lowers dramatically. At least, according to Helen. She seems to know more about the green monsters than everyone else. It's a bad idea to ignore her advice.

"Helen," I say, after thinking it over, "you're in the camp for rushing over there. What's our exit strategy if things go south?"

"Just teleport us back. You put a beacon inside Axis Mundi, so returning will take a minuscule amount of energy." She says this with a straight face, apparently unafraid of showing up to a planet that may be hostile to our very existence.

"Fine. Let's pop in, then pop out if things get dicey. I won't tell anyone to go. Just come along if you want to, and be prepared for danger."

Ben crosses his arms. "Count me out. I don't give a damn about the Volgrim, and I ain't taking a chance with those little green fuckers. I'll stay here, so at least if you lot get turned,

there'll be *someone* competent to lead what's left of humanity."

"What an optimist," Ylvusk grumbles dryly. "I agree with the shadow-human, though. I'm staying right here. No way I'm messing with those things."

"That's fine," Samantha says, "but your friend is coming along with us. He might be able to sense the Kolvaxians."

"Aw, rats," Tvoorik mutters. "Fine, I'll go. But before I do, I have one question to ask."

Samantha eyes him suspiciously. "What's that?"

The Seer stabs a finger in Cassiel's direction. "Is it true? Were the angels working for Satan all along? I saw a vision, so you can't lie to me."

Somehow, Cassiel manages a straight face. "No. They were not."

"Bloody hell." Tvoorik lunges a foot forward and kicks a pebble across the ground. "But this Hero guy is a robot, right?"

It's my turn to glare at him. "No."

"You're zero-for-two, Tvoorik. Just drop it," Ylvusk says, before slugging his friend in the shoulder. "He has a bunch of dumb conspiracies. Please ignore him; you'll thank me later."

Tvoorik rubs his shoulder and mutters something under his breath, but I don't catch it. Then he glares at Ylvusk. "You're gonna make me go with them alone? I thought we were best buddies!"

"You're the only one who says that," Ylvusk replies. "I mean, maybe I said it once or twice, but that was before I realized you were a big dummy."

"Alright, that's enough. We're wasting time." Helen breaks up their petty spat and pulls them apart. "Jason, take us back to Axis Mundi. It'll take a few minutes to fire up the reactors so we can get the Void-Spanner online."

"Okay. Take care of this shadow-walker, Ben. We'll be back soon."

"I'm ecstatic," Ben says, a look of annoyance on his face.

" Return. "

* * *

Soon the five of us, Helen, Cassiel, Samantha, Tvoorik, and I, are standing in front of a giant metal circle, with steps leading up to its center. It looks a lot like the portals I constructed in Hero City.

Tvoorik nudges me. "You know, I once told Ylvusk that Satan faked his death. I'm not always wrong."

"That's nice," I say, trying not to be rude.

"Did you *really* destroy one of our bubble-worlds with a meteor?"

The memories come bubbling back to me. "Yes. It was an accident. I only meant to deal heavy damage to a battlefield, but I summoned a giant rock that wiped out all life on the planet. I still regret it."

He nods excitedly, apparently paying no attention to my mood. "Wow! I always thought that was a lie! So what about-"

Samantha appears at Tvoorik's side and leans on his shoulder. "Fewer questions, more silence. Don't make me regret bringing you."

His face pales. "Y-yes ma'am." He's very willing to cow to strong women. I wonder if he has a masochistic side.

Helen is standing over at a console with Cassiel, pointing out a bunch of numbers and explaining how the portal device works, and after a minute they both walk over.

"It's almost ready. Just another few seconds to go."

I nod at Helen. "Nice."

A spark of energy forms at the center of the gate, and soon several bolts of energy arc from the circular frame and shoot into the center as a tiny hole in the air forms, expands, and quickly grows to the full size of the monument itself. At twenty feet wide and thirty tall, it's big enough that the five of us can walk through it side-by-side, with room left over.

The other side of the portal is pitch-black. I stare at it for a moment, unable to see anything, until Helen holds her hands up and emits a ray of light that passes through the portal, lighting up what appears to be an underground cavern.

"It's an underground cavern," Helen says, as if she can read my mind. "The Volgrim don't know of its existence."

"I don't see anyone nearby," Cassiel whispers, as she takes a step toward the portal. "It's creepy."

"Darkness can feel like that sometimes," Tvoorik says nonchalantly. "So, what are we waiting for? Let's go!"

"Slow down, flyboy." Samantha pushes him aside, then walks up and takes Cassiel's hand. "We'll lead the way. Cass, increase your brightness to light the place up. Be ready for anything."

Wordlessly, Cassiel raises a finger, and her body's aura increases dramatically, turning her into a human-sized lightbulb. She and Samantha step through the portal into the cave, and I

follow behind them, eyes jerking back and forth. Helen and Tvoorik trail behind me, and Tvoorik whispers something to her, but she smacks his shoulder. "That's rude! Jason can't help the way he looks!"

I don't know what he said, and I don't want to know.

Quickly, I scan the caves and take in my surroundings. Stalactites hang from the ceiling, their greenish color formed from a rock I don't recognize. Small puddles of muddy water dot the ground under each one, as a reddish liquid drips down from the rock formations above. The cavern is empty, despite my expectation of bats hanging from the ceiling. A faint vibration greets my feet as I walk around.

"What's that humming feeling? It's like the ground is alive."

Helen pauses and cocks her head. "I don't know."

Slowly, we trudge through the cave, and the sound of compressing air in the distance, like a *whoomph* reaches our ears. When I jerk my head back in alarm, Helen quickly raises her palm. "The portal closed, that's all. We'll be relying on you to take us back to Axis Mundi if anything happens."

"Oh. Okay. I'm just a little nervous, that's all."

Cassiel lights the path in front, and Helen from the rear, as I keep to the middle. I'm not sure why we silently chose this formation, but it has the advantage that it protects me. Since I'm the only one who can teleport us back if things go south, it's essential I be in the safest position. That being said, I don't like that my girlfriends are taking point.

Tvoorik whispers again, and this time I hear what he says. "Is it true what they say about humans with small feet?"

"You're disgusting," Helen hisses. "Shame."

Cassiel and Samantha walk in total silence, holding each other's hand as they trod forward until Cassiel pauses and points up ahead. "Dead end."

Helen sighs and pulls away from Tvoorik, flapping her wings and flying over the girls and me with that surprising agility of hers. She lands smoothly and quickly scans the recessed wall. "Ah, this is the exit." She leans forward, reaches into a hole I didn't notice, and does something inside of it, quickly retracting her arm. The wall shudders and slides open to reveal a perfectly chiseled staircase, although a bunch of the reddish liquid pours out from the opening and soaks the floor before retreating into the stagnant puddles around us. The smell is putrid, like the worst mold I've smelled in my life.

Cassiel gags audibly. "Gods, I think we've discovered where a Fartsmith once lived."

Samantha coughs and laughs, even as tears pour out of her eyes. "Kah, haha! G-good one, Cassy."

" **Sanitize.** " I speak a word and instantly the foul odor vanishes, leaving everyone blinking dumbly for a moment as the cleanest, most wonderful oxygen ever reaches their nostrils.

"Wow. You'd make a good janitor," Tvoorik quips. "Do you work on commission?"

I ignore him and push past the girls, walking behind Helen as she ascends the stairs. "I think it's best I take the point. We don't know what's up there."

Helen hesitates before pressing herself against the wall to let me squeeze past. The stairwell is cramped enough that I can feel her breath as I press by, and once I'm on the other side, I quickly hike up the stairs, carefully pressing each foot against the floor so that I don't make a sound. Nobody says a word until we climb the hundred or so steps to the top, and a flat metal ceiling greets us.

I shoot a glance back at Helen. "Is this the exit?"

"Yes. There's no activation; you need to either blow it outward or remove it with Wordsmithing. It was designed to be nearly impossible to find."

"Oh. Simple enough. **Remove.** "

The word leaves my mouth, and the metal above vanishes, causing a humongous mound of dirt and shrubbery to cave in, falling down on me suddenly. "Ah!" I barely get the word out before dozens of pounds of rock and grime slam onto me, knocking me over and burying me in an avalanche of debris.

I quickly jump up, burst out, and cough madly, spitting dirt and filth everywhere. "Pwah! Ptoo! Blech!"

When I look back, Samantha is trying to force a look of concern, but Cassiel stifles a laugh. "Nice one!"

"Oh, shut up. **Clean.** " The dirt and other crap vanishes, and my body and mouth instantly restore to perfect condition. Turning around, I look up at the incredibly bright sky above. It's an eerie purple, a color that makes no sense compared to anything I've seen before. "The hell's with the color?"

Helen jumps, pushes against the wall, leapfrogs over me, and jumps out into the open air, landing in the field a few feet away. She quickly crouches down, splays her legs out, and takes a defensive stance. Before she can say anything, my eyes lower and I look into the distance. Massive plumes of smoke rise into the sky, as a city made of futuristic buildings a few miles away burns to the ground.

Helen wheezes. "I think we're too late, sweetheart."

Part 476c: Apocalypse

The purple sky gives a feeling of other-worldliness to this... other-world. Everything is tinted by a hue that makes the pale skin of my girlfriends turn a sickly blue. The ground is covered with tiny red plants that remind me of brambles, and not a sound can be heard anywhere in the world nearby. While I might expect to hear distant screams from the Volgrim city burning to rubble, nothing reaches my ears. No animals, birds, insects, or any other creature wander the plains before us, though several miles away I can just make out the top of some trees, which may or may not lead to a forest.

Cassiel gingerly walks over to me, the blood-red brambles crunching loudly under her feet. They're drier than a sack of potato chips. "We're too late."

"Yeah." My fist clenches as I gaze into the distance. I'm no fan of Volgrim, especially after they attacked us, but that could be chalked up to several misunderstandings. Nothing I've heard about the Kolvaxians leads me to like them at all. They're monsters that convert other species by force. They're... they're like insects. A hivemind of murder and violence. Not even the Volgrim deserve to be turned, like Ben's crew were.

Tvoorik and Samantha crawl out of the cavern behind us, and I notice that Tvoorik isn't slouching like he usually does. His movements are oddly alert as if a facade of goofiness has worn off. He points at the Volgrim city. "There. Three million, four hundred thousand, nine hundred and twelve Volgrim are still alive."

"What? Seriously? How could you know that?" I glance at Samantha, but she merely nods. Apparently, his word is accurate.

The vibration I felt in the cavern increases noticeably, and the ground shakes slightly beneath us. Helen crouches down a little and glances around warily. "What is that? What's causing this rumbling?"

All of a sudden, gigantic cannons rise from the area near the city walls and simultaneously aim into the sky. I can't see anything through the smoke and cloud cover above, but all of them begin blasting rapid-fire energy shots into the air, each one sending out a shockwave due to their incredible kinetic force. Waves of dirt and debris explode outward from each cannon and begin surging in every direction, including toward us. Cassiel jumps forward and raises her hand, and a barrier of light forms, encircling our group. Several seconds later, the wave of debris surges the few miles in our direction, moving at incredible speed, and smashes into her barrier, but she doesn't flinch, and the light holds perfectly, protecting us from any damage.

Helen's jaw drops, and she stands up, visibly awed. "Cassiel, that's incredible! How are you able to form a shield like that? There was only one time I saw anything of the sort, and it was from one of the legendary heroes!"

Cassiel shrugs and looks at Helen, unfazed by the wall of debris blasting her barrier. "Jason gives me lots of energy. This much is nothing."

"Cocky," Helen laughs. "Don't let it go to your head. Still, I'm impressed."

After a minute, the debris slows down, though the cannons continue to barrage the sky. Whatever they're attacking, it must be in space. The rumbling continues to increase, and now it's becoming hard to stand as my knees shake around. "God-damn! What the fuck is causing this?"

Nobody answers. They don't need to. The sound of an alarm, not unlike a nuclear siren I might have heard on Earth, wails in the distance. *Woooop! Woooop!*

My body shivers as something unthinkably huge begins to rise from the city. A spaceship. Buildings crumble around it as it climbs upward, foot by foot, slowly inching higher into the sky and crushing the city around it to rubble.

Samantha's eyes bulge, and she gawks at the behemoth. "Sweet mother of the devil! I've seen capital ships that weren't that big!"

The alarm cuts off awkwardly as a return barrage of artillery flies down from space, blasting apart the city and the surrounding area. I quickly raise my hand to the sky. " **Barrier! Barrier! Barrier!** "

Cassiel breathes a sigh of relief as my power adds to hers, amplifying the strength of her magic. Each energy blast is the size of a BMW, and they explode with incredible force, blowing chunks of dirt and rock into the stratosphere as hundreds, if not thousands of shots pummel the mega-ship.

Tvoorik continues to point, but this time at the ship and not the city. "Taking damage. Structural failure imminent. Scared. Volgrim have no emotion. Volgrim should not show fear. Still scared. Cannot help it. Oh." He lowers his arm as the barrage from whatever vessel is orbiting the planet stops, leading me to think they have to reload or something. A second later, as the last enemy shot hits the ground and silence overtakes us, a focused laser of incredible strength shoots down from the sky and pierces the Volgrim capital ship, increases in size, and slices outward, sawing the ship in two.

The rumbling under our feet slows, and the ship falls, slowly at first, then faster and faster until it smashes into the city below. Another shockwave ripples out, and the land rumbles

toward us, like a tsunami made of dirt and stone. Cassiel's bravado falters, and she squeaks, though she also pours even more energy into her barrier. The tide of rock and dirt pounds into her shield like a million megaton hammers, creating a sound that I can only describe as tens of thousands of tin garbage cans being bashed together, all at once.

A few minutes later, everything becomes still. The five of us gasp and wheeze, partially due to the effort it took to keep standing, but mostly because of terror. The level of destruction we just witnessed was on a scale that made us realize just how small and fragile we are.

Cautiously, Cassiel lowers her barrier. The assault has ceased... at least for now. "Tvoorik. You can sense how many Volgrim are alive, right? Do you know-"

"Six hundred and forty," Tvoorik says before she can finish. "The ship's hyperdrive was punctured, causing a cascade of exotic particles which tore the flesh from the bodies of every Volgrim they touched. Since this happened in the seconds before the ship fell apart, the ship contained most of the breach inside of itself, which simply means we are in no danger from the particles. However, the ship containing the explosion meant that every life-form on the inside was microwaved instantly. There are no survivors."

I stare at the demon, blinking, for a few moments. It's hard to understand what he just said. Compared to his idiotic demeanor from earlier, he's practically a nuclear physicist all of a sudden.

Samantha eyes him suspiciously. "How could you possibly know all that?"

"I don't," He says, before pointing his finger several miles away from the city. "A research facility. Scientists are inside. Those are the only remaining Volgrim on this part of the planet."

After a moment, I register his words. "Wait, you mean there are other Volgrim elsewhere?"

Tvoorik's body visibly relaxes, and his shoulders sag before he flashes a smile at me. "Yup! Whole bunch of 'em. A few million, maybe. One of their leaders was thinkin' something about a fleet nearby with the rest. They're evacuating the planet, but many had to stay behind in bunkers."

"Oh. Good to know." I shoot a glance at Samantha, but she shrugs. Neither of us knows why he transitions from idiot to guru in the span of a few seconds before reverting again. Maybe it's his mutation? 'Seer,' huh? It sounds a little intimidating, honestly. Perhaps I underestimated him.

Helen coughs and rubs her eyes. "Ugh, I didn't expect to arrive in the middle of a war-zone. We need to find those Volgrim survivors and-" She pauses suddenly, and all of us stiffen at the sound of multiple sonic booms above our heads. Everyone jerks up to scan the skies, and Cassiel

quickly forms another barrier. The clouds part all at once as hundreds of fireballs streak down, aimed at the city in the distance. It only takes a few seconds for the objects to scream into the ground, but instead of explosions, only deep *whumps* can be heard.

Several fireballs careen through the sky and land with a bang just a mile away, kicking up small clouds of dust, but compared to what the mega-ship did; they're nothing.

Helen looks at me. "What kind of attack was that? Are they synchronized bombs? Maybe they're going to detonate all at once and level the city."

"God, I hope not." I hold my hands up to shield my eyes from the planet's sunlight, squinting as I stare into the distance, but I can't make anything out. After a minute, I suddenly realize I'm dumb. **Storage.** " Reaching inside, I pull the Crown of Solomon out, throw it on my head, and wordsmith again. " **Drone. Drone. Binoculars.** "

Two observation drones appear in midair and rapidly fly toward the city, and I hold the binocs up to my eyes. They're far more advanced than something I'd have found in a pawn shop back on Earth, since they can magnify by a factor of a hundred times and track onto objects, stabilizing my view. Since they have infrared and several other vision modes, I can see many things with them that I can't with my bare eyes.

My mental link to the drones activates, and I can perceive what both of them see, in addition to the vision from both of my eyes. It's slightly disorienting, but I get used to it shockingly fast.

Tvoorik mutters something beside me, but I don't catch it. I carefully stare at the crater and as the dust clears...

"Hey, there's something in those craters. Metal. Like a... like a pod, of some sort. An escape pod, maybe."

Someone grabs my arm, and I quickly lower the binoculars to see Helen staring at me intensely. "Pods, you say? Are they circular?"

"Yeah. Why?"

Her eyes flick over to the smoldering craters. "The strike force. They leveled the city, so now it's just a matter of sending the troops down. Each of those pods has a Kolvaxian inside. We've got a minute before they find us."

"What? Seriously?" I feel panic rising. "How? They're miles away! Did they detect us already?"

"They don't have to, Jason. Kolvaxians have several abilities, and while their scope is hard to pin down, one of those abilities is to detect objects and things on the landmass they're standing

on. In other words, we're standing on solid ground, and once they are, they will find us. It won't take long."

"That's crazy," Cassiel hisses. "We need to start flying, then."

"No, we should leave. The Volgrim are doomed. We're far too late." Helen shakes her head ferociously. "Let's get out of here."

I quickly put my foot down. "I don't know how the Kolvaxians fight or anything about them, but Tvoorik says there are 600 scientists in that bunker. I can't just leave them to die."

Samantha and Cassiel share a look of uncertainty. Sam chews her lip. "Helen knows more about them than we do. We should listen, I think."

Cass looks me in the eye before turning to Helen. "Jason's right. If he leaves them to die, he can't call himself a hero. We have to save those we're capable of saving. Just because the Kolvaxians have incredible fighting power doesn't mean we should just back down. We'll never win that way."

Huh. I never realized it before, but Cassiel is kinda heroic herself, sometimes. "I can send you guys back if you want. I'll keep Cass, since her energy may help me fight the monsters. Either way, every second we spend discussing it is a second we're wasting. They'll get out of those pods soon."

Helen doesn't know what to say. She glances in the distance, then back at me. "Cripes. If you send me back, you're as good as dead. You'll need my knowledge about them. Cassiel, grab Samantha. I'll take the little demon. Jason, you fly with us. Make sure you don't touch the ground. They're going to spot us in the air, but they don't have many ways of taking us out once we're up there."

"Good to know. I have a better idea, though," I say, before aiming my mind at Tvoorik and Samantha, as well as myself. " **Wings. Wings. Wings.** "

Samantha sprouts a leathery demonic-looking pair of wings, though Tvoorik's are more scaly, like a dragon's, and pitch black. They erupt out the back of his robes, tearing them to ribbons in the process. "Shucks."

As for me, mine are feathery, like Cassiel's. *Odd, I didn't give any particular thought to how the wings should look, yet each person has wings with unique characteristics. Wordsmithing can be mysterious, sometimes.*

"Okay, start flying. It might take a minute for you to get used to them, but-" Before I can finish my sentence, Samantha leaps into the air, and her wings flap gracefully, as she does a loop-the-loop.

"Whee!"

I'm glad someone's having fun.

Tvoorik is much less agile, but he still flaps his wings and rises into the air competently, as do Helen, Cassiel, and I. Once we're airborne, I turn to Tvoorik. "Where's the facility?"

He points again. "Oh, it's about that direction. A few miles or so. I'll be more specific once we're closer."

"Cool beans," I mutter in response. Secretly I doubt my decision, but I'm glad Cassiel is backing me up. Even so, staying here might be suicide. These little green monsters sound like the stuff of nightmares.

The five of us quickly cover lots of ground. Our wings allow us to move much faster than a bird, thanks to their magical properties. After a minute or two Tvoorik slows his flying to a stop, then points at one of the nearest pods. "It's open."

Below us and ahead perhaps a few hundred yards is one of the metal pods lying in a crater by itself. The hatch to it has opened forward, and a small amount of steam still hisses from its sides, which makes sense given it must have heated up a lot when it entered the atmosphere.

"The monsters have been loosed. Be on your guard," Helen says, as if we weren't already tense enough to crush iron with our stomachs.

A flash of movement below catches my eye. It's a barely noticeable blur, vanishing before I can lock on it with my eyes. "Down there! I saw something!"

Everyone spins to see where I'm pointing. Sweat pours off Cassiel's brow. "Huh? What did you- AH!" She lets out a yelp of fright and suddenly plunges feet-first toward the ground, as if she's being dragged down by something.

"Cassiel!" I fly after her immediately, as she screams in panic. Her body careens down, and she flaps her wings to try and stay aloft, but she's unable to slow her descent, as if a ten-ton wrecking ball were chained to her leg.

"Jason! It's got me! There's something... guh!" She's cut off as her body slams into the dirt, smashing onto the recently disturbed terrain with bone-snapping force. She can't even let out a cry of pain as the breath blasts out of her body. Her mouth opens and closes, but as I land beside her, she can't make a sound and instead struggles to breathe for a few moments.

"I've got you! **Heal!**" I quickly Wordsmith, and a second later she inhales sharply as tears pour down her face.

"-got me! It won't let go! Get it off, get it off!" I reach down to pick her up, but her arms turn into a flurry of movement as she starts swinging and flailing at her legs, apparently trying to

pull something off her body. "It's wrapped around my leg, Jason!"

I don't know what she's talking about; I can't see anything there. However, a closer glance reveals depressions on her skin, as if several invisible hands were clutching at her, trying to tear her leg off. I try to swat them off her leg, but my hand passes through whatever's gripping her.

Another flash of movement catches my eye. A few dozen feet away, something emerges from the ground, startling me. I realize instantly it must be a Kolvaxian, only it's not quite what I expected. It has smooth green skin, with lots of moisture visible everywhere, as if it had just climbed out of a mossy lake. The alien monster thing hisses like a cat, and its bulbous eyes twitch and jerk from side-to-side for a moment. "Kss..."

Cass stops flailing around for a moment to gaze at it in horror. "Is... is that a-?!"

A second later, I'm nearly blown away as Samantha flies down from the sky with incredible speed and delivers a stone-shattering punch right into the Kolvaxian's body, blasting the monster to kingdom come with the force of... well, with the force of Samantha punching something at subsonic speeds. I wouldn't want to be the monster, that's for sure.

Cassiel gasps as whatever was holding her suddenly vanishes, and the force she was putting into pulling away from it is released. She leaps backward, nearly knocking the wind out of me as our bodies collide.

She doesn't apologize, instead opting to make the fastest motion of her life with her hands, healing me. "Go! Go!" She can barely get the words out since her body is shaking so much.

The dust settles from Samantha's impact, and she jumps back, eying the impact site warily. "I missed! It vanished into the ground the second I made contact! Watch out!"

All three of us quickly fly into the sky, though this time I hold Cassiel's hand in case whatever grabbed her before tries again. "Are you okay, Cass?"

She nods despite being shaken up by the experience. "I was terrified, but it's over now. I felt like a hundred invisible men were grabbing my leg and pulling me wherever they wanted. How did the freak do that?"

Samantha gnashes her teeth. "I don't know, but Jason, you need to keep Cass close. There must be a reason it targeted her."

We fly back to where we were before, only this time we keep going higher until the pod below is a speck. Once we feel high enough that we're safe, we stop and let Tvoorik and Helen catch up to us.

I turn to Helen. "That thing grabbed Cass! I thought you said they couldn't get us in the air!"

Confusion presents itself on the older woman's face. "I don't know how it did that! Kolvaxians have always had an aerial weakness!"

Tvoorik stares listlessly at the ground below. "Telekinesis. Volgrim."

"Huh? Telekinesis?" Samantha shoots him a questioning look. "You're saying that's how it nabbed Cass?"

The short demon nods. "Unique. She has too much energy. She's drawing their attention with her special-" Tvoorik pauses suddenly, and his eyes cloud over. He stiffens to gaze at us. "You will add to our perfection. You will increase our power. We are unstoppable. We are unrelenting. Do not run. Do not hide. Join us, and experience terror and bliss. Join us, and free yourself from pain and sorrow."

All four of us pull away from Tvoorik reflexively. I raise a palm toward him, readying myself to blast him with everything I've got. "Tvoorik... buddy? Are you okay? What's going on?"

Tvoorik continues to stare at us, his eyes growing more unfocused than they were a moment ago. "You are chaos. We are order. You destroy. We repair. You weaken, but we grow stronger. All will fall before us. None are worthy."

After a moment, Tvoorik blinks, and his breathing turns ragged. His entire body sags as if a great weight were released from his shoulders.

The four of us look at him uneasily. "What the hell was that?" Samantha asks.

Tvoorik rubs his eyes. "Their minds are strong. Their thoughts are overwhelming. I felt like I was connected to a trillion beings all thinking the same thing at once. It was... unsettling."

I think I'm starting to understand. As a Seer, Tvoorik can connect his mind to the consciousness of others, due to some telepathic abilities. Somehow, when he does this, it changes his personality, usually increasing his intellect. That, or he's crazy. I can't discount the possibility.

Cassiel reaches down and rubs her legs, then gazes at the ground below. The Kolvaxian from earlier is gone. "Tvoorik, who was speaking? Did you connect to one of the monsters?"

He nods and points at different spots on the ground below. "Yes. There, there, there. Three of them. They're hiding under the surface. I tried to unite my mind to theirs, but I was overwhelmed. I can't do that again, or I might lose myself."

"Okay. Let's stay high and hope they don't grab us again with... whatever they used." I turn to Helen. "You're certain they never had such abilities before?"

"Not that I know of. Perhaps they developed telekinesis recently. Kolvaxians adapt quickly, and constantly learn new abilities."

I nod, realizing time is even shorter than it was a few minutes ago. "Alright. We need a shortcut. I'm going to jump us to the Volgrim scientists. Be ready for action."

Aiming my mind, I target about where the bunker should be, even as a thought enters my mind. *If the Kolvaxians were able to speak through Tvoorik, then were the words he spoke theirs? And if so, what is their goal? What do they hope to achieve? Are they not mindless monsters after all?*

The five of us are engulfed by my spell at the same time. " **Teleport.** "

Part 477c: The Floor Is Lava

With a single word, I transport the five of us a dozen miles across the open plains, and we teleport a few hundred yards above the area Tvoorik pointed out from before. The instant we appear, everyone takes a defensive stance, and we put our backs to each other, whipping our heads around to search for threats. Now that we're much closer to the city, the smell of burning flesh and crumbling infrastructure force our instincts to sharpen. Something about the danger in the air forces the human, and apparently the angel and demon body to tense up.

The land below us, once covered by blood-red brambles, is now torn apart and ripped up. Fresh dirt covers everything, leading to a gross brown surface in every direction. If the Kolvaxians were walking around, they'd stick out like a sore thumb.

Tvoorik points again, this time directly below us. "There's a door. It leads to a hangar big enough to fit a small spacecraft. The scientists barricaded the entrance and are holed up inside, weapons at the ready. Their chances of survival are zero."

"Without us, at least," I reply. " **Structure.** " Using my Wordsmithing, I quickly create a mental picture of the internal structure, sending the information to the Crown to hold, and allowing it to create a new mental map for me. "There's a long corridor just inside- looks like the scientists have set up some auto-turrets. They use anti-energy in addition to plasma, so Cassiel's shield probably won't hold up. I'll teleport us where the majority of them have hunkered down. Cass, create your shield before we jump, just in case they freak out and start blasting."

Cassiel smiles tightly. "Right." She holds her hand up, and a balloon of white energy surrounds us, making us stand out in the sky, but no Kolvaxians appear. I'm worried their invisible arms or whatever will grab Cass again, though at the same time I keep wondering why they're hiding. Are they burrowing underground? Why the secrecy?

A passage from a book I once read comes to mind. *Secret operations are essential in war.* One significant advantage the Kolvaxians have is their secrecy. Even Helen, who has watched Jason Alpha fight them for a trillion years (or however long it's been) doesn't know how they operate. Nobody knows where they come from, or what their goal is. Total dominance? Peace? If we don't understand them, we can't fight them.

Maybe that's their action plan.

Cassiel shivers as a gust of chilly upper atmospheric air hits us, bringing the smell of death with it from below. "Shield's ready whenever you are, Jason!"

I aim my mind inside the compound. " **Teleport!** "

All five of us vanish and reappear, and it takes a few seconds to reorient ourselves once again. This time, I absorb the faces of hundreds of Volgrim pivoting to stare at us in shock, and their reflexes are put to the test once they realize intruders are in their midst. Before I can say "We come in peace," a hail of plasma smashes into Cassiel's force field, though I breathe a sigh of relief as none of the weapons they're using are anti-energy. I suppose they wouldn't be much use against the Kolvaxians, given their bodies have anti-energy in them. Why would that be the case, anyway?

" **Malfunction.** " I speak again, and every gun in the room jams at once and stops firing, courtesy of the Crown expanding my knowledge of their workings.

Helen quickly holds up her hands and speaks in fluent Volgarian. "We are your allies! Please stop shooting!" Her wording is slightly comical, given I just jammed their guns. Oh well.

Images of males and females shaken up over the losses of vast swaths of the population greet me as several of the scientists lower their trembling hands. Compared to the commanding presence of that Kryios Volgrim from before, these people are barely holding on to sanity. The room is filled with piles of guns, spears, metal boxes and benches overturned to form barriers in case of a firefight, and two of the four corridors leading into the room are completely barricaded. The path ahead leads to the hangar where the Kolvaxians will likely enter, while the way behind probably leads deeper underground where the scientists will be unable to flee any further. *A deathtrap*, my mind whispers.

"You! Who are you?" One male tentatively steps toward us, a gun in each hand. The Crown identifies the weapon in his right hand as a plasma pistol, while the one in his left fires anti-energy. Both are disabled already though, but I don't think he's realized it yet.

"We're friends. We've come to save you from the Kolvaxians," Samantha says, as she takes a cautious step toward him.

"Friends? You're not even Volgrim!" The male inserts a small amount of pride in his voice, though it sounds weak and ineffectual, given the circumstances. Unlike the scientists, this one has a slight air of authority to him, not unlike someone stuck at a dead-end job in middle-management. Essentially, he thinks he has power and authority, but really doesn't.

I sigh and heave my shoulders in the air. "Ah, I guess you're right. We aren't Volgrim. Well, since you're being picky, we'll just leave. I'm sure you can stop the planet-busting enemy force outside all by yourselves."

That calms him down. He glances at the others before looking back at me. "Fine, you've made your point. What can you do to help? The best weapons we've got won't last long, and now that they've converted the Elders, it won't be long before they simply shut down our defenses."

"I can't fight the Kolvaxians," I say, though in my head I think, *at least, Jason Alpha can't. If he's more powerful than me on a scale of millions, I probably shouldn't chance it.* "What I can do is get you out of here. Where are the other Volgrim on the planet? I want to teleport as many as possible to safety."

A female against the wall to my left gazes at me questioningly. "Why? You say you're an ally, but what do you have to gain from saving our lives?"

Nice. Questions. Just what I want to hear at a time like this. "I'm not doing this out of obligation; I'm doing it because it's the right thing to do." I turn to Helen. "I'm going to teleport them to Axis Mundi. That work for you?"

Immediately, her expression sours. "Please, no. Nobody is supposed to know of its existence. Keeping the existence of the angels from the rest of the galaxy is why Alpha created the place. Just put them in Hero City or something."

I pause to think about it. Hero City has a population of perhaps a hundred thousand. Most humans live on outer-worlds that Hero City's central portal hub links to. A few hundred Volgrim could comfortably fit in there, but there might be millions of others that I have to save. Hero City is a short-term plan, though when I put things in term of population, Axis Mundi is the far worse choice.

Wait, I just remembered a second option!

"Hey, you." I turn back to the Volgrim male. "You said the Elders were turned... were they the highest authority among Volgrim? Who's in charge now?"

The man stares at me blankly. "I don't know, human. There is no formal command structure right now. We've lost contact with the other bases. I suspect a signal scrambler is being aimed at the planet."

"Fantastic. That makes things easy." I speak two more words, aiming my mind throughout the cosmos to find the one I seek. " **Locate. Teleport.** "

A moment later, a familiar Volgrim female appears in the middle of the room, her mouth freezing open mid-sentence as the sudden change in surroundings disorients her. Her shock barely lasts a moment before she starts spinning around, looking at every individual in the room, taking all their images in at once as she tries to understand what's going on.

Her eyes spot me, and she continues to look around but does a double-take once she remembers my face. "Ah! You- what did- where-?!"

I cut her stammering off. "Dosen, long time no see, except not really."

The former Second Founder of the Volgrim blinks multiple times before taking a deep breath and staring at me, forcing a neutral expression. "Jason Hiro, what are you doing? I was right in the middle of something."

"It's an emergency. The Kolvaxians are about to wipe the Volgrim off the face of the galaxy, and your people need a leader to take command and gather-"

She holds a hand up to interrupt me. "Kolvaxians? Invasion? What are you talking about? I can barely understand what's going on."

Oh god. This is going to take a few minutes. As that thought enters my mind, the sound of automated turrets activating and firing hundreds of shots at once makes everyone in the room jerk their heads around to look back down the hallway that leads to the outside world.

Shit.

"Uhh..." I freeze, unsure how to speed things up. After a second, a solution comes to mind. I aim my mind at Dosena's. "**Share.**"

A stream of thoughts and memories from the past few weeks copy from my mind to hers, including everything I know about the Kolvaxians, the battle with Satan, and even Jason Alpha.

A stunned expression passes over Dosena's face as she violently recoils from the sudden flood of mental information. She starts to fall backward, but once again Helen demonstrates surprising agility and dashes forward, catching the former Second Founder before she hits the ground.

"Jason! Give a little warning next time!"

Dosena's speech slurs for a moment, but she quickly shakes the handicap off. Pulling herself to her feet, she glares at me for a moment. "It's beyond rude to invade the personal space of someone else's mind. Something you would know if you were born Volgrim." After a pause, her anger fades. "That being said, I somewhat grasp the situation. Why do you need me?"

The sound of metal scraping against metal makes my back seize up as several turrets stop firing. A few others continue, but it's clear the Kolvaxians are ripping the static defenses to pieces. Many of the scientists smack their guns, trying to get them working again, but given I disabled them, that won't solve the problem. I quietly mutter, "**Repair.**"

Satisfied their guns are working, the male from before starts setting up a defensive perimeter while I try to explain to Dosena what I want. She listens to me intently, but I can see she doesn't like it.

"I left that life behind, Jason. I'm not fit to lead a people I have nothing in common with. I don't know millions of years of their history, who my subordinates would be, or anything else."

You're free to put the refugees on Voldarius for a short while, but we haven't the food nor the living space for them to stay long. Your kindness is always going to be limited by external factors."

She gives me a fairly definitive *no*, but at the same time, food and living space aren't an issue, given I can just increase the planet's size with Wordsmithing. I don't have time to argue with her, and I got a 'yes' for the important question, so it'll have to do.

"Thanks, Dosen. I'll talk with you later. You need to reconsider for the good of your species. **Teleport.** " I don't give her a chance to deny me again, instead opting to send her back to Voldarius before she can respond. Then I quickly aim my mind at clumps of the scientists standing nearby. " **Return. Return. Return.** "

Each cluster of Volgrim takes a few seconds to focus on, send, then continue, and after a rapid session of mental math, I realize it'll take at least a couple of minutes before I can send them all.

Luckily, Cassiel notices. "Keep teleporting them, Jason. The four of us will attempt to slow the Kolvaxians down."

I nod and continue speaking. " **Return. Return. Return.** "

Cassiel and Samantha run to the beginning of the hallway that leads to the hangar. By now, the turrets have all been blasted to smithereens or destroyed. The silence from that direction is deafening, but despite tearing the defenses to shreds, no enemies have started moving down the corridor toward our position.

Tvoorik glances back and forth before grabbing Helen's arm and hurling her to the middle of the room. "Below!" She yelps awkwardly, right before spotting a Kolvaxian appearing from under the metal-plated floor. As if made of pixie sparkles and unicorn farts, the fucker jumps from the ground to swipe at where her leg would have been, before hissing and grabbing for Tvoorik instead. I pause my wordsmithing for just a moment to deliver a violent kick to the thing's head, but it sucks back underground in the blink of an eye, and I nearly shatter my ankle pounding the ground.

Tvoorik keeps his cool, and his eyes quickly begin moving around, roving the ground below as he mentally tracks several *things* below us. "Twenty-four. They can phase through solid objects."

"Great!" Helen shouts. "Everyone, watch your feet! They're trying to nab us one-by one and-"

She doesn't get to finish. One of the female scientists screams in fright as a Kolvaxian leaps from the ground, stabs its hand forward, and impales her through her stomach, then yanks her

down, pulling her under the floor in the span of a single second. It's at this moment I realize the awful truth. *Going underground was a fatal mistake. This is their most advantageous position.*

Indeed, as long as we can't take to the skies, the green bastards can grab us anytime they want, and we're at their complete mercy. Since they have none, I have to move quickly, or else it won't be the scientists who fall today. For several seconds, as I continue returning them to Voldarius, I ponder sending my friends and I instead and leaving the Volgrim to their fate.

You can't save everyone, Jason. You'll never be a good enough Hero. You're nothing compared to the legends of the past. You're a failure.

A voice inside my head whispers to give up. It's that 'other me,' the one who haunts my dreams and turns them into nightmares. I can't listen to him. If he's right, then what am I fighting for? What's the point of anything? Why should I even-

"Jason! JASON!!" Cassiel screams in fright as three Kolvaxians leap from the ground, one of them hissing and biting onto her shoulder as she cries out in pain, and the other two grabbing her by the legs and pulling her down. She tries to fight them off, but in less than a second, she'll be pulled under!

Samantha darts forward and pounds the first Kolvaxian that bit her right in the face, delivering a clean blow while grabbing Cassiel's hands at the same time. "Cass! Don't let go! Don't let go!"

Cass is already half-buried, and she screams in terror. "Get it off! Get it off!!"

I leap forward and pound the ground with my fist, then begin yelling out a word repeatedly. "**Earthquake! Earthquake! EARTHQUAKE!!**"

Violent rumbles start hurling people around the room as the planet transforms from a solid object into a tsunami of movement. I wrap my arms around Cassiel and pull up with as much strength as I can muster, but it's as if the lower half of her body is trapped inside a fucking black hole! No matter how the ground shakes and crumbles under my feet, it's like I'm trying to lift a skyscraper with my bare hands.

Cassiel slips down another inch or two, and several other Volgrim scientists shriek in terror as they're hurled around the room and grabbed in midair by more Kolvaxians, but I don't give a shit about them anymore. *I won't let them take Cassiel! I won't!*

Suddenly I feel pressure on my back, and a horrible pain as I realize several Kolvaxians have jumped on me and started biting. The anguish from an unknown poison rushing into my

bloodstream almost doubles me over and makes me let Cassiel go, but I won't do it! I can't fail her! I can't allow the voice in my head to be right!

Samantha screeches in fear as a Kolvaxian leaps onto her back as well, then starts throttling her and twisting with all its might, cutting her voice off mid-yelp before biting a substantial chunk out of her shoulder.

Hah hah hah... I warned you, idiot. You'll be turned and transformed into monsters. You tried to fight a plague that even a thoughtsmith with tens of millions of years of experience couldn't overcome. You tried to play hero with the lives of a few hundred worthless Volgrim, just so you could feel good about yourself, all while ignoring the tens of millions the Kolvaxians already turned or killed. Why bother? Give up. Accept your fate with dignity.

A face appears before me as numbness floods my body. It's my face, again. *What is this, the second time now? The third? How many times will you let them die? If only you were stronger! If only you were smarter! But you aren't, because you're worthless! You'll never put your mind to use, because you can't even-*

Shut up!! Shut up!

My eyes jerk open as an idea forms. The crown! Use it, idiot!

Wordsmithing and magic won't work on these fuckers, and if that's the case-

" COPY! COPY! "

My mind aims outside the bunker, into the sky and the space above the planet. Several hundred Kolvaxian vessels lie in wait, but I only need one shot.

In the void, a tiny speck appears, insignificant compared to the size of a capital ship. Then, another does. Two tiny, trivial satellites, copied from the one orbiting Hero City.

Target! Aim! FIRE!!!

"Cassiel! Shield! NOW!"

I don't get a chance to find out whether she heard me or not.

A light, like staring directly into the sun, engulfs everything. A titanic beam of energy, caused by two fusion reactors blasting our position with every ounce of power they contain, destroys every speck of land for a hundred miles around.

The light transforms into darkness.

I can't see.

I can't hear.

I can't feel.

Maybe I'm dead. Nobody could have survived that. It was a blast powerful enough to rip apart two small planetoids. Yeah. I'm definitely, one hundred percent gonezo.

After a moment, my vision clears. I'm... falling?

Falling? Why?

Wind whistles past my ears. Cassiel is unconscious. Her sleeping face is cute... so is Samantha's. Oh look, there's Tvoorik and Helen, just above us.

Why are we falling?

Oh goodness, that's hot on my back. Where's the heat coming from?

Casually, I turn my head behind me. *Oh wow, an absolutely massive pit of magma, and we're falling toward it. That is going to burn once we hit it. Yep.*

I should definitely do something about that.

Aaaaaany time now.

Any second.

HOLY SHIT!

" Teleport! "

All five of us jump away seconds before splashing into a fiery hot death, and I send us way over to the east, where we land safely on a soft patch of ground. Our bodies smash into the dirt with sickening *crunches*, but I wheeze for a moment before tilting my head to look at the others. Cassiel landed on top of me, and Samantha just off to the side, but Tvoorik and Helen are a couple dozen feet away.

Cassiel's skin is discoloring, and fast. For the second time in a day, her soft complexion is mottling at a visibly alarming rate. Even Samantha's skin is doing so, though Tvoorik and Helen don't seem to have been bitten by the Kolvaxians.

" Hea- kah! Heal! Revert! Heal! Revert! "

I quickly repair the damage Cassiel and Samantha took, wheezing in satisfaction as their skin slowly reverts to its normal coloration. Reaching up to wipe my head, I suddenly notice my skin is greening as well. Shit! Idiot! Always give yourself medical attention first!

" Heal! Revert! "

My phlegm-filled throat thanks me silently as a horrible buildup of mucus vanishes.

As I wait for the others to wake up, I finally notice my surroundings. To my right lies the crater that my dual cannons in the sky formed. It takes me a second to comprehend the scope of the devastation. The entire city that the Volgrim once lived in is gone.

All of the scientists I didn't teleport out in time... they're dead. Cassiel didn't have a spare second to protect everyone. What if I hadn't rushed? What if I had realized the Kolvaxians could attack from underground? What if I'd just teleported them to Voldarius without wasting time explaining things to Dosen? I could have done that afterward. They're dead because of me.

I can only take solace in the fact that I killed a few of the Kolvaxians as well.

" **Destroy.** " I speak the kill command to each of my weaponized lasers in orbit, blowing them apart in spectacular fashion. Even here, miles below, I can see faint blips of light as the remaining energy in their reactors detonate, reducing two machines that may have given the Kolvaxians an extra advantage in the war to fragments of their former selves.

The clouds, while mostly uniform in the sky, split in half above the impact site where the lasers of ultimate death pierced them from before.

Despite the sunlit sky, I can see a few stars above. They're beautiful.

After a moment, I sigh. *Those aren't stars, idiot. Those are Kolvaxian warships. In the next minute or so, they'll probably launch more pods to the surface.*

Helen stirs. "Ahhh..." She slowly pulls herself together, a notable feat given her body was broken in several places just a minute ago. She rubs her back and cautiously pulls herself to a sitting position. "J-Jason...? Where- no, what happened?"

"I saved the day. We triumphed against the Kolvaxians," I mutter dryly. "Everything went according to my brilliant plan. No regrets at all."

She doesn't pick up on the sarcasm. "That's good to hear. What happened to the scientists- oh my goodness!" She suddenly notices the giant crater filled with magma bubbling in the distance. We're much too far for the heat to reach us, but a worry appears in my mind that it could erupt and shower us with agony, not unlike the figurative fires of Hell.

"Yep. That's all me. Best Hero in the universe." I toss my arm toward the devastation flippantly. "That used to be where the scientists worked. Nothing left of it now."

She stares at the crater for several long moments, as Cassiel stirs in my arms. "Are they all dead?"

"Mhm. The Volgrim, as well as the Kolvaxians. I doubt-" A thought occurs to me, and I pause. *I may have leveled the area, but hundreds of pods fell from the sky. There might be other Kolvaxians underground nearby! Only Tvoorik can sense them.*

I can't keep overlooking details. " **Wake.** "

Tvoorik suddenly jerks up, as alert as if he'd never been knocked unconscious at all. Still, he takes a moment to look around before noticing me. "What happened?"

I quickly fill him in, and he nods. "Ain't nobody around. They'll probably send more, but I dunno. We should get out of here, while we still can."

A voice speaks up from my left, startling me. "Yooo! What's going on, guys!" I turn to spot myself waving at me. Once I notice the glowing skin, I realize who it is. "Jason Alpha? What are you doing here?"

He smiles cheerfully before pausing to notice all the people lying around on the ground, dazed or unconscious. "Oh you know, I was doing a bit of this and that. I was gone a little longer than I expected, but otherwise- whoa! What's that giant crater? Where even are we?" He quickly looks around, and I stare at him in dumbfounded awe.

"Did you just get here?"

Harold appears at his side. "Yeap! I told him this was the wrong time coordinate, but this dummy never listens to some old geezer like me! Oh what do I know, I'm just a dumb, stupid old man!" He rolls his eyes and strolls over to Helen. "Heya sweetie! What've you been up to while we were gone?"

She flashes him a genuine smile before winking at me. "Oh, you know. The usual. Existential horror and terror coupled with crippling loss and the realization nothing we do will save every life."

Harold merely nods as he leans over and kisses his wife on the cheek. "'Bout par for the course, I'd wager- HOLY SMOKES! What the hay are you kids doin' takin' a vacation on the crater of a live volcano?!"

I sigh and shake my head. *Wait until he finds out what they missed.*

Part 478c: Consequences

Jason Alpha and Harold examine their surroundings, trying to figure out what's going on. It only takes the old man a few seconds, but the other me is a little bit slower on the uptake, and certainly more relaxed. "Helen, sweetheart... what were ya'll up to? This don't look like the ding-dang Labyrinth ta' me."

Jason Alpha nods. "This planet is familiar. The sky, especially. I'd never forget a purple sky. Where is this?"

Helen jumps to her feet and dusts her clothes off before quickly glancing at Cassiel's body, still laying in my arms. She hasn't awakened yet, even though I healed her. I get the impression there may have been feedback from my cannon that hit her and Samantha a lot harder than it hit me. "Now, Jason- err, Alpha, I mean... I'm going to tell you something that might... might make you a little angry."

The other me raises an eyebrow. "Angry? Pft, come on. What could you possibly say that would piss me off?" His smile slackens somewhat as Helen's somber expression greets him. "Are you serious?"

She nods. "This world is familiar to you because you've been here before. However, the volcano behind us wasn't here last time." She flicks her gaze over to Harold. "This planet is Melkin."

Both of the newcomers' smiles slowly fade. Harold rubs his chin. "Melkin? Ain't that the new Volgrim homeworld? Thought I told ya not to pop over here without an escort. It's mighty dangerous."

Jason Alpha's eyes dart to the magma once again. "Hold on... Melkin doesn't have any below-sea-level concave volcanos. This dirt was disturbed recently... were you in a fight?"

He asks the question, and I resist the urge to facepalm. *No, Samantha and Cassiel are just sleeping at the edge of a volcano for no reason, dumbass.*

Helen swallows audibly. "Yes, and the fight didn't go so well. Jason, Harold, this planet, and this entire galaxy, is under attack. The Kolvaxians have somehow traveled here, and they've been here a long time."

Both men turn deathly silent. Jason Alpha slowly rubs his right hand with his left, playing with an odd-looking ring on his middle finger. He slowly pulls it slightly off, then pushes it back

on, repeating the process several times, like a nervous tic. "Helen. That's not funny. I've told you not to joke around. Your humor is the worst."

"Son, I don't think she's joking." Harold nudges Jason Alpha, but the other me doesn't respond. His cheek bubbles out as his tongue lashes around inside his mouth, and his eyes give Helen a thousand-yard stare.

"It- it's gotta be a joke. Helen wouldn't- I mean, we couldn't make a mistake- they couldn't show up here. We have the infection contained... we have the infection contained."

Tvoorik slowly walks over to Jason Alpha. "Launching. Up." He points to the sky, but it takes a couple of seconds for Jason Alpha to shake off the cloudiness in his eyes before he slowly tilts his head up.

In the space above, small specks of light begin descending toward the planet, but they're probably hundreds of miles away.

Alpha inhales sharply. "Invasion pods. I've seen those a thousand times." I realize after a second or two that he must be silently enhancing his vision or perception with Thoughtsmithing to zoom in on each pod. "Son of a whore. I can't- this is unreal. How could they have escaped the K universe?"

Helen rubs her hands together and bows her head before speaking, but she's barely whispering. "You shouldn't blame yourself for this, but... when Volgarius was destroyed during the Energy Wars, I think it created a tear in subspace. They probably entered through there."

Jason Alpha bobs his head. "Oh. Ah. I see."

Compared to his usual joking manner, he's a different person entirely. He's suddenly a human, and not a living god. He's seen the face of death and faced it head-on, but something about the Kolvaxians is worse than death to him.

After a few moments, the specks of light fade from the sky, likely landing somewhere out of sight.

"Fuck." Jason Alpha lowers his head. "I can't believe it. It's my fault. I never considered- I mean, I didn't think about the consequences. I should have realized-"

"Kid, don't beat yourself up." Harold grips Alpha's arm firmly. "You screwed the pooch, but you can still fix it."

"Maybe." Jason Alpha forces a smile, but it's half-hearted. "Or maybe not. If they've made it to this universe, we have to entertain the possibility they might be in other ones. I can't track them with Locate since their bodies interfere with my magic. It's a guessing game at this point."

Harold pulls away from Alpha and turns to his wife. "So you's was fightin' them here? What caused the crater?"

"Me." I quickly give them the bullet points on my death-laser and how two energy blasts melted away a chunk of the planet's surface.

Alpha clears his throat. "That was quick thinking, Sparky. A bit reckless, but I guess it got the job done." He gestures toward the girls, both of them still breathing shallowly. "Are Belial and Sarah okay? They haven't woken up yet."

"I dunno. I think they were hit by the energy more directly than me, hard to say." I pause, realizing what he said. "What do you mean by 'Sarah'? Her name's Cassiel."

"Uhh..." Jason Alpha pauses a moment before quickly shaking his head. "Oh, right, right. My bad. I must have mixed her up with... someone else." His playful demeanor from earlier returns, but there's a certain pain in every syllable, as if he's forcing himself to stay positive for our sake.

Alpha points at Cassiel and Samantha. "Bloop. Bloop. They should wake up now. You missed a bunch of radioactive scar tissue in their brains. Amateur mistake. I don't think Cassiel's aura was erected in time. Still, given this level of devastation, it's surprising you guys survived at all. Her abilities in this stream are something else."

"This stream?" I echo his words. "What does that mean?"

"Ehh... multiverse time travel stuff. Really boring, you wouldn't understand. Hell, I barely do, and it's my daily life."

Cassiel and Samantha both blink their eyes open almost simultaneously, and Cass slurps up some drool that was leaking out. "Oh god, what happened? I feel like I made out with the front end of a spaceship doing warp 10." I help her to her feet, and while she is a little shaky, she manages.

Samantha rubs her forehead and flops on her back. "I'll just stay here for a minute if you don't mind, love."

Alpha rubs his hands together. "Okay, so, if I understand you correctly, Kolvaxians are not only in this universe, but they also have made it to the Volgrim homeworld too? Pretty coincidental timing, if you ask me."

"Hey! What do you mean by that?" I try not to glare at him too hard, but I can't help my reaction. "Are you blaming me?"

Before Alpha can answer, Cassiel leans against me. "Um, Jason, we *did* activate a Sentinel that wiped out tons of the Volgrim reserve forces. We're not blameless."

Shush, Cassiel, I want to say, but I can't. She's right, after all.

"Oh gods, Harold, how long were we gone? I thought we came back after three RTU's?"

The old man shakes his head. "Ah, I screwed up. It's barely been one."

"One?! Well, that's fine. We got back in time to avert the destruction of Melkin, so it all worked out-"

Samantha raises her hand and interrupts him. "Um, excuse me! I have a question!"

Alpha flashes an annoyed stare at Sam for cutting him off, but begrudgingly sighs. "Yeah?"

"What's an RTU?"

I consider her question and realize I don't know either. I think Helen mentioned them once, but I wasn't paying attention.

Jason Alpha waves his hand nonchalantly. "Oh, you know, time travel jargon. Real-Time Units, meaning a fixed amount of time relative from one universe to the next. It's a little complicated."

Samantha nods, apparently satisfied. "I see. I have another question, then... are you going to let the Volgrim die? Those Kolvaxian pods were aimed pretty far away..."

Alpha fidgets around and messes with his ring again. "Well, you guys aren't needed now that I'm here. I'll call in some friends of mine and do what I can, but aside from obliterating their fleet in orbit, I can't do anything for the planet. Once they go underground, they're invisible to me. They've even learned to confound echolocation, so this planet is toast."

Helen slowly shakes her head. "What a shame. I should have checked in more often and tried contacting the Volgrim once and a while."

"It's not your fault, Helen. If anything, it's mine. They're showing up here because of what I did to this galaxy. Don't beat yourself up over my mistakes." Jason Alpha shakes his head and sighs. "God damn. I can't believe myself. If going back and changing my past actions wouldn't cause a split, I'd be able to fix this easily, but unfortunately, that's not how time travel works."

I want to ask him ' *Then how does it work?* ' but Volgrim are dying every second we waste, so it's better I don't take up his time. "I'll take us back to the Labyrinth, then. Are you sure you don't want my help?"

"No. Actually, I need to talk to you about what I learned while I was jumping around, but that will have to wait until later. Time's short, as you know."

A distant *whoomph*, like that of an explosion over the horizon, reaches our ears. Samantha jumps to her feet. "Okay, lazy time is over. Let's get out of here and stop slowing him down."

I stare at my time-traveling compatriot for a moment as a hundred questions enter my mind. They'll have to wait.

Before I can teleport us away, Jason nudges Harold. "You won't be any use against the Kolvaxians, gramps. You can fill them in on what happened. I'll be back... soon."

"Expected 'bout that much," Harold says.

Well, I guess I will be able to figure out what's going on, after all. A lucky break, for once!

Aiming my mind at Harold, in addition to the other four, I nod silently at Alpha. "See ya. **Teleport.** "

Just before we vanish, I catch one last glimpse of Alpha. He rubs the ring on his finger and bows his head, and a look of sadness washes over his face. A fleeting expression of loss.

Part 479c: Bonds

Papers covered in scribbles litter my desk. Some are drawings, while others have hastily scrawled notes, and all of them serve one purpose; solving *the mystery*. I've long wondered how the foundations of demon society were built, and how we managed to come out on top during the Energy Wars. Demons are not educated on our past, and instead, are told to set our eyes on the future. As such, only the eldest of our kind know the details of our rich history, and they keep those secrets clutched firmly to their chests.

The candle beside me sputters, and I quickly snap my fingers to reignite it. Some of these scrolls are essential to understanding our past, but I've only just begun the search. Time is my enemy. With Satan gone and myself assuming the mantle of leader over all demons, I have to understand where we came from to understand where we should go.

"Emperor Beelzebub." A female voice speaks out from behind me. Soft, fragile, alluring. I turn my head back slightly to see my beautiful assistant, Titania. Her blood-red hair, the color of fire, stands out against the black and gold armor she dons. I may call her an assistant, but as the eldest progenitor of the Phoenix from ages past, she's more of a warrior than an associate. Her job is to guard me, though such a task is more of a formality given my incredible magical power.

"Titania. Something to report?" I try to keep the annoyance out of my voice, but it isn't easy. I haven't left this room since I returned from the battle that sent Satan scurrying away like a whipped hellhound. Rumors are floating around regarding my absence, but I can't be bothered to entertain them.

She opens the door to the room slightly and steps inside. "I've brought the former Second Emperor, Lord Diablo, as you requested."

Her eyes dart to a spot just behind my chair, where I've been tossing wadded papers of useless information. Anything that doesn't advance my knowledge of the past is merely a distraction from my goals. As interesting as *The Formation of the Siren Songs* might be to scholars, that information is just a waste of my time.

"Good. Bring him in. You have the rest of the day off."

She smiles faintly. "Thank you, your Grace. I'll send him in at once. I hope your research turns out well."

Titania leaves, and I sigh as I wait for her to send in my old nemesis. Perhaps calling Diablo a 'nemesis' is giving the fool too much credit. He *did* part with his power too quickly for my

liking. He probably knew something I didn't, which is why I'm going to interrogate him today.

A minute passes as I wait. My foot starts tapping impatiently, and I turn back to the papers on my desk. Many of them are benign, uninteresting at first glance. What I've discovered though, as I read through them, is that all the scrolls created before the end of the Energy Wars were tampered with. In fact, the editing is blatant enough that I was shocked someone would be so bold.

However, it isn't that someone has crossed out sentences, or wiped out whole lines. Rather, it's that where previously there were whole paragraphs, chunks might be missing here and there, as if they had never been written in the first place. References to people, places, and things are gone, like they never existed. Not even Diablo's magic is potent enough to undo what I assumed might be hexes or magic hiding the existence of said sentences.

"You rang?" Diablo's bland voice at the doorway makes me jerk in surprise. I quickly spin on my chair to face him.

He's wearing much plainer clothing than he used to as Emperor. His tall body is no longer as girthy as it once was, likely due to how much energy he's lost. He's slimmer now, like a demon who has gone on an extended exercise regimen. Oddly, Bael is the one everyone points to when it comes to body training, yet his bulk only increases as the centuries pass.

I take a moment to exhale, calming my nerves. "Diablo. So glad you could drop in."

"Uh huh." He rumbles in his throat, then yawns and stumbles over to a bench against the opposite wall and plops down on it, sighing contentedly. "Not like I had much choice. I thought you weren't going to bug me."

"I changed my mind," I say, narrowing my eyes at him. "You may have noticed the papers and scrolls behind me."

"Not really. I make it a point to avoid paperwork these days." Diablo flippantly tosses his hand in the air. "It's the easy life for me. I hope you didn't bring me here just because you couldn't handle the job."

"No! I can handle the job just fine, thank you very-!" I pause, realizing I just allowed him to goad me. He's pushing my buttons, deliberately. "This isn't about the job. I have questions that need answers. You were alive before the Energy Wars, and you were at the highest echelons of demonic power, so only you can answer them."

"Ah, so it is work." Diablo leans his head forward and rests it on his fist. "Can you make this quick? I want to sleep some more."

I nod slowly. "Do you know the true identity of the First Emperor?"

"Huh? Oh, you mean Asmodeus. If that isn't his true identity, then no, I don't."

I lick my lips slowly. "His real identity is Satan."

Diablo yawns and stares at me blankly. "Seriously? I guess that makes sense."

A moment passes, and the two of us gaze at each other. His blank expression meets my dumbfounded one. "That's it? You're not surprised, annoyed you never knew, or angry?"

He shrugs. "You're trying to get a reaction out of me, whelp, and you'll fail. If he's Satan, then it doesn't surprise me. If he isn't, then it doesn't matter."

With a flourish, I pull one of the scrolls from my desk and unfurl it in front of me. "It does matter. Haven't you looked into our history? Haven't you ever wondered what happened after the Energy Wars? Why did we end up in a position of subservience to the Volgrim? How did humans conveniently end up in our care where we could feed on them? Why didn't-"

Diablo holds up a hand, interrupting me. "Stop. I get it. You're the Second Emperor now, and you want to make a big impact by examining our past to change our future. I had thoughts like that at one point. I read the scrolls from the ancient tombs too. Nothing you find is going to change anything. It doesn't matter."

Slowly, I roll the scroll back up. "I'm not the Second Emperor anymore. I'm the First."

Diablo's aloofness vanishes and is replaced by surprise. I've finally gotten to him. "What? Bullshit. There isn't a chance you dethroned Satan, or Asmodeus, or whatever he calls himself." After a pause, he smirks. "You couldn't even beat *me*."

"I'm not lying, and I didn't defeat Satan. He's gone. He left the Labyrinth and our universe." I pause, thinking of how best to break the news. "I haven't told anyone else yet, not even Titania. Satan is a Wordsmith, just like Jason Hiro. He's traveled to another universe, or time... or something. He doesn't exist in our realm anymore."

My former superior takes the news quite well. "Ah. So that changes what, exactly?"

"What do you mean?! It changes everything! Confound you!" The flame of the candle behind me rises dramatically as my temper flares. "I'm the number one leader of demonkind! I need to know our history! I need to know what path I should take!"

Diablo sighs and shakes his head. "Hah... look, Beelzy-"

"Don't call me that."

Irritation appears on his face, but he continues. "I was the Third Emperor for all of my life after the Energy Wars, but considering Belial was never around and Asmod- err, Satan didn't care about our people, I was essentially the First Emperor, just as you were once you took over."

Satan leaving doesn't change anything. Only one thing has changed in recent years, and that is the appearance of Jason Hiro. That's why you called me, isn't it? You want to know how to deal with him."

He isn't asking me a question; he's stating a fact. My nails dig into my knees as I stare him down. *I hate how he reads minds without having any telepathic abilities.*

"Maybe. I met another Jason, one who time travels just like Satan does. He bested Satan in a battle and made it look effortless. After the two of them left, I realized I couldn't hope to beat Jason Hiro, the one I know, let alone his other self. That one is a god on par with the Creator. But... but..."

A long silence follows. I struggle to find the words to say, though the thoughts fill my mind effortlessly.

I can't ally with humans. I hate them. Demons hate them. Even if some could forgive their differences, humans are food for us. Livestock can never be our equals, nor our allies.

Diablo rubs his hands together slowly. "I hate humans too, you know."

"What? You do?" I stare at the old codger in surprise. "Everyone calls you a human-lover."

"That's a lie. I'm too lazy to protest, so I just let other demons talk. The flaws that you see in humans are not the flaws I see. You see weakness, avarice, and greed. I hate that they represent the worst of demonkind unabashedly, without restraint. Demons at our worst can never compare to the pure evil a human can unleash."

Diablo turns his head away to stare at the room's entrance. "Were it just for the flaws of humans, I would see to it that they were hunted down and exterminated, soul power be damned. The problem is that not all humans are evil beyond belief. What humans possess in raw rage, hatred, and dark deeds, they make up for with equal quantities of love, generosity, and care for others."

A few moments pass as Diablo closes his eyes. "You weren't alive for this, but perhaps you can understand the situation on Earth before it was destroyed if I explain it carefully. Are you familiar with Mermaids?"

I raise an eyebrow at him. "Yes. Why do you ask?"

"Mermaids were a folk tale among humans. Some swore they existed, while others wrote them off as a tall tale for children's stories. Of course, Mermaids did exist, and they all died when the planet was destroyed, but they provide an excellent example of the human psyche."

Intrigued, I nod along. "How so?"

"The worst humans would lavish their lustful desires on mermaids, hunt them down, capture them, and do horrendous, vile things. Some would hunt mermaids for sport, turning their corpses into trophies to show off. However, the best humans would protect the mermaids with their very lives, offer them any amount of sanctuary, and would even form guilds on the sea to hunt down pirates and slavers. This is why the myth of mermaids persisted, even long after they had gone into hiding in the deepest trenches of the oceans. Occasionally, some lucky sailor would be treated to a kiss due to a mermaid observing his kindness. Perhaps he would release fish in secret back to the seas, and later would be tossed overboard by his more unscrupulous companions. The mermaid, seeing his kind heart, would swim the poor sailor back to land, saving his life."

Diablo finishes, and I continue nodding. "I see. So, what you're saying is that there are good humans, and bad ones?"

"Not exactly," Diablo sighs. "Humans tend to be very pure, or very evil. Most wars were caused by their worst, and yet they were usually ended by their best. The fact that demons are living peacefully among humans in their city proves they can show kindness toward our kind, even after all the fighting both sides have endured."

I quickly point at him. "Haven't you forgotten? The human king, Elshard, locked all of the demons in Hero City in work camps."

"Tch. After several demons attacked him in the safety of his palace," Diablo says, as he waves his finger at me chidingly. "And it was Jason Hiro, the one you hate so much, who had the demons released once he returned. Funny, hasn't he been the one trying to bring peace among the sentients for several years now?" Diablo suddenly glares at me. "And don't give me that bullshit about him killing and enslaving you. I know the trouble you've caused over the years, especially during your youth. You were a naive, petulant imp, from what I've heard."

The candle flickers in the room, and I cross my arms and legs, then lean back in my chair. "It's not the same thing."

"He was alone in the Labyrinth, demonic enemies at all sides. Once he began to understand the scope of the world he had arrived in, Jason Hiro began undertaking steps to repair the damage he'd caused. You were one of his victims, but he tried to help you fit in. He gave you a purpose and things to do, even if you loathed him for it. Honestly, he was too good to you."

"Too good?" I repeat Diablo's words, tasting them and rolling them around on my tongue. "Maybe you are a human-lover, after all."

Diablo's knuckles crack as he stretches once more before standing up. "Look, Beelzebub, it's simple. Humans ruled by a righteous leader will gravitate toward becoming a wonderful, loving,

caring society. However, if they are taken over by a lunatic, a madman, one bent on the destruction of our kind, they may grow to be unstoppable. Why not lay the foundations of peace now? If you continue to attack them, you will only give their worst elements a voice. They will preach to any who will listen, and they will say 'Look! The demons are as evil as we warned! We should build horrible new weapons and wipe them out!' Is that what you want?"

"Well, no. I don't believe the humans can wipe us out, though. Even with the help of the Wordsmith, our numbers are too great. We can hold them back indefinitely."

Finally, Diablo grows silent. He eyes me cautiously, and a dreadful feeling fills the air. His mood darkens.

"What if humans aren't the real enemy? What if I told you there was another?"

"Another?" I force a smile. "You mean the Volgrim? Admittedly, they have technology that puts humanity to shame, but-"

"Not the Volgrim." Diablo shakes his head slowly. "Not angels, humans, or Volgrim. Something else. Something... worse. A plague."

My memories trace back to the battle between Jason Alpha and Satan. One piece stands out from everything else.

Quietly, my voice nearly a whisper, I force the words out. "Sentinels..."

"Huh? No, dumbass! Not the Sentinels either!" Diablo jumps from his seat and claps his hands together. "Something worse than- alright, seven devils, I'll just say it."

He pauses to draw a breath. "The Volgrim have been fighting an enemy in secret for millions of years. The reason the Volgrim care so little about the Labyrinth or exterminating us or anything else... they don't have the time or the resources to spare. The enemy they fight are unstoppable killers, which the Volgrim have dubbed 'Kolvoxians'."

"Kolvoxians," I repeat the name to mark it in my memory. "Are they dangerous?"

"Supremely. In fact, I received news very recently that the Kolvoxians might be pushing to attack the Volgrim core systems. If they fall, the Labyrinth, and demonkind, will likely be next."

"Seriously?" I can barely contain my shock. "But... the Volgrim are..."

"Unstoppable? Hardly." Diablo slowly begins pacing, balling the bottom of his shirt up in his fists as he stomps back and forth. "The Volgrim, from my sporadic memories of the Energy Wars, lost several times to the humans. Only their unleashing of the Sentinels put an end to the war. Perhaps. Come to think of it; I don't remember how the Sentinels were defeated." Diablo taps his lip thoughtfully before shrugging and carrying on. "In any case, the Volgrim are far from infallible. I know little of the Kolvoxians beyond what I've gleaned from the Volgrim

council when I visited them. They were always spoken of in hushed whispers, but I could tell they terrified the Elders."

While Diablo paces, I fit the puzzle together in my mind. "If I understand you correctly, you think we should ally with humans, not just because you think such a peace would be beneficial for us, but because it would help us fight the Kolvaxians more effectively. Does this mean we should seek to tighten our bonds with the Volgrim as well?"

"Yes, though I fear it is much too late for that now." Diablo starts for the door but pauses before opening it. "I believe the Volgrim are already dead on arrival. If my message reached him in time, Jason Hiro might be able to do something, but I can only hope he can save them. More likely than not, he will fail."

"Don't give the *fleshbag* too much credit there, human-lover," I say, poking fun at the former Third Emperor. "I won't promise anything. Hell, you haven't answered the questions I asked when you first showed up."

"I have," Diablo replies, as he smiles at me. "The questions you spoke, and the questions you thought, they were not the same ones. I don't have the correct answers, anyway. I'm hardly omniscient. I'm just giving you my opinion."

For once, I smile at him genuinely. "Well, it helped. This is the second most useful thing you've ever done for me."

"What was the first?" Diablo glares at me suspiciously, before chuckling. "Oh, right. I hope you don't abuse the power I gave you. It comes with great responsibility."

"I won't. Everything I do, every step I take... is for the good of demonkind."

"As it should be." Diablo reaches for the door and pulls it open. "You know, Beelzebub, you should find a mate. If you get rid of some of your pent-up frustration occasionally, it'll do wonders to clear your mind. Perhaps that cute thing you call a guard?"

"Pass," I hiss at him. "Don't press your luck, old bat."

"Hey, I'm just sayin'." Diablo steps out the door and pulls it shut behind him. Just before he leaves, he says, "Take care, young one."

Minutes pass. I stare at the entrance, half-expecting him to come walking back through, but he doesn't.

Ally with the humans, huh? Should I?

I... hate them. Genuinely. Wholeheartedly.

I could never shake hands with that Elshard... the worthless king who shoved me into a work camp. Not even Jason Hiro could encourage me to form a bond with humanity.

However... there is one I don't hate. Not a human, but...

Part 480c: Dilation

The five of us inhale sharply as we arrive back at Axis Mundi. Well, Harold doesn't, but he's a robot. The stress of everything we've just been through hits us like a ton of bricks, and everyone, including me, slump down onto our butts. A dozen angels nearby turn to stare at us quizzically before returning to their business, and Cassiel lolls her head back to sigh at the ceiling.

"I'm glad we're out of there."

"Same," Samantha replies. "I saw my life flash before my eyes. I can barely understand what happened."

Figuring now is as good a time as any, I quickly bring her, Cass, and everyone else up to date on what's happened in the last 24 hours... so we're all on the same page. Tvoorik shakes his head and wanders away after a while, uninterested in our conversation, but Helen and Harold nod along, and Harold leans forward, interest in his eyes.

"Kid, sounds like you've had a heckuva time while I was gone. Still, y'handled it pretty well. You're more reliable than Alpha thinks."

"Uh, thanks." I try not to sound offended. "Just how unreliable does my grandfather copycat think I am?"

Harold coughs into his fist. "Kah, well, ahm- it ain't the way you think it is. I guess from yer perspective, we done left for less than a day, but from our point o' view, we was gone for a few years. He learned a bunch o' stuff, and he had a lotta time ta' think about'cha."

Helen jumps in. "A few years? Goodness, Harold! I know he gets sidetracked sometimes, but even for him, that's absurd! What were you two up to for all that time?"

Harold waves his hand dismissively. "Get off mah back, woman. Cripes, a few years ain't nothin' when you're as old as we is." The old man mumbles and grumbles for a second, but comes back around. "Truth be told, we lost the devil. Satan vanished, just like he always does. Even Cassy's energy wasn't enough to track the bugger."

"You lost him? I mean- how?!" I can barely keep my jaw from dropping. "Isn't Jason Alpha like, a god? His energy is ridiculous! I thought you guys had the drop on Satan!"

Harold holds his palms up. "Satan's done it a hundred- no, even a thousand times. Every time we catch him, he jumps away and vanishes off the grid. We can't track him or nothin'. 'S weird, too. Damned devil's a friggin' ghost."

A few moments pass as Harold *hems* and *haws* and his wife gently rubs his back. I don't know why she bothers, given his robotic body, but maybe he has skin sensors or something. He's probably hyper-advanced and I don't even know.

Samantha raises her hand. "Um, I think I might know why."

"Ya what?" Harold shoots her a curious glance. "Whatcha mean?"

Samantha rubs her hands slowly. "I don't know if I understand how you track Satan around... but it's something like when Jason-" She points at me, "-when Jason says 'Locate,' right? That's how you usually find him?"

"Mhm." Harold and Helen grunt simultaneously, giving me a chuckle. As husband and wife, they mirror each other occasionally.

Samantha turns to me. "How does Locate work for you? Can you describe it specifically?"

"Sure, I guess." I pause to think about it for a few seconds. "I say 'Locate,' then I picture the person I want to track, including their face and name. The better I know them, the easier it is to find them. It doesn't take much, though."

"Right. But aren't there limitations to your Locate ability?"

Samantha asks me the question, and I feel gears slightly clicking into place. "Well, sure. But those limitations are pretty simple. I can't locate inanimate objects or things hidden by anti-energy. Satan is neither inanimate nor able to hide inside of anti-energy, so he couldn't be exploiting those edge cases." I stare at her carefully. "Unless you mean that's what he's been doing?"

"No, I doubt that." Samantha stands up and brushes some dirt off her soft, wonderful butt. "But you said it yourself. You have to picture a face and a name. So what if Satan changes his face and name?"

"Huh?" Harold raises an eyebrow. "What would that accomplish? He'd still be Satan."

"It's just a hunch." Samantha rubs her arms and shivers. "I- when Jason here gave me back my memories, I remembered all of my interactions with Satan in the past. He would always start off as a giant demon, calling himself 'Asmodeus,' and when he d-drew closer to me, he would change his form back to his normal self and call himself Satan again. Since we know he has that mindsmithing or whatever, then isn't it possible he-"

Helen yelps, catching everyone off guard. "Gods! She's got it! He's changing his identity with Thoughtsmithing so we can't find him!"

The old woman's enthusiasm is contagious. Much like how replacing a burnt-out bulb in a Christmas light arrangement will reactivate the others, Harold rears up and smacks his fist into

his palm. "Sonofagun! Yer right! How come- why didn't we think o' that?!"

Samantha smiles weakly. "I was m-more intimate with Satan. You probably don't know him as well as I do. I always thought it was weird he was pretending to be someone else. Now I know why."

I stare at my girlfriend silently, evaluating her presence. Her eyes glance away, toward the distance, the ceiling, anywhere but meeting mine. Dwelling on her past with Satan disturbs her every time she thinks of him. Considering she once professed her undying love for him, I can only wonder what memories I unlocked in her mind to evoke such a dramatic change in emotion. Now it's as if he's an enemy she wants to cut down, yet also fears.

The feeling of something latching onto my arm nearly makes me jump in surprise, but I quickly swivel my head to see Cassiel wrapping her arms around mine. "Sammy's pretty smart," she whispers. "But you're giving her a weird look."

While Samantha and Helen talk to each other about her theory, I keep my voice low, so only Cass can hear me. "Do you know what Satan did to her? I can see it in her eyes. She hates him now, but I don't understand why."

I feel Cass's grip on my arm tense up. "Oh, that's what you were- um. It's not my place to say." She pulls away from me suddenly and tucks her wings in slightly. "It's private. You should ask Sammy."

"I thought you'd say that."

Christ. I don't get women at all. Samantha, especially. She's been weird for a few weeks now. She keeps hiding trivial things from me, like when she wouldn't admit she beat the crap out of Diablo. I think it was because she didn't want to hurt my manly pride, but if she knew me as well as I wish she did, she'd know that wouldn't bother me at all. Hell, I'd be glad to have someone reliable like her at my side. If I had to protect her constantly, she'd feel useless and like luggage holding me back, and that would eat away at me as well. She's my equal in many ways, superior in some and inferior in others. Just like Cass. Both of them are the gasoline to my fire, lighting my passion and potential aflame. I want to protect them, but at the same time, I don't have to. They can hold their own.

Come to think of it; they've protected me several times now. Where would I be if Samantha hadn't crushed Diablo? He might have killed me, and all of those humans as well. As for Cassiel, her healing magic has saved countless lives, mine included. Not to mention her staggering spiritual energy capacity, like a miniature star waiting to explode into a supernova. When it comes to raw power, she has me outclassed. Hell, she dealt a blow to Satan that stunned Jason Alpha! She's incredible. Both of them are. I'm lucky to have them at my side.

Whatever Satan did that has Samantha running scared, that pissed her off, or anything else, I need to support her. It's not a matter of hurt feelings; it's a deep scar that wounds her more than anything else she's faced yet.

"I'm sure Alpha'll tell you that stuff," Harold says, interrupting whatever question Samantha just asked Helen. "We didn't do all that much, t'be honest. After Satan skedaddled, we spent a while lookin' for him, but our hearts wasn't in it. Then we went over to visit the Central Hub, 'n we chatted with the Maries. They told us some stuff about some o' the other universes, yadda yadda, all boring stuff if y'ask me."

"The Maries?" Cassiel perks up at the familiar name. "As in... Marie Becker?"

"Oh! Ya know her?" Harold scratches his face. "Odd. The one in this stream is a quiet gal. She ain't talkin' to the rest of 'em like she used to. How d'ya know her?"

He smiles pleasantly at Cassiel, unprepared for what's about to come. I flinch in preparation for a barrage of vitriol, but Cassiel keeps her calm, surprising me. "We're *acquaintances*." Despite her simple reply, the last word is overflowing with sarcasm.

Harold completely misses the venom in Cass's voice. "'Kwaintences, eh? That makes things real easy. Anywho, all the Maries oversee the Multiverse and do a bunch of stuff that would bore ya ta' tears. They make sure everything's linked up and nothin' asplodes. Stuff like that."

Helen nods. "She's a good friend, even if a little coarse and rough around the edges. Honestly, if it weren't for her, I don't know how we'd manage. Jason isn't the brightest-" She pauses, suddenly feeling self-conscious when she realizes *I'm standing right here*. "Err, well, she has certain *qualities* he doesn't."

Nice save.

Harold turns to his wife. "We're gonna have to pay her a visit as soon as Alpha gits back. She's gotta know bout them Kolvaxians. I reckon she won't be mighty happy."

"Alpha wasn't. Nobody is." Helen shakes her head.

The five of us gaze around for a few moments, until Tvoorik swaggers back over, seeing that our conversation has died down. "Alpha's about to pop back over. He's almost done with the Melkin situation."

"Already?" I stare incredulously at Tvoorik. "How fast does the guy move?"

"At the speed of thought," Tvoorik replies simply.

"Okey-doke, all done!" Jason Alpha's voice suddenly rings out, making everyone jump except for Tvoorik, who is already staring at the spot Alpha appears from. Teleporting in, Alpha strides into the middle of the circle, but the smile on his face seems more plastic than usual.

"What do you mean, 'all done'?" Harold asks, suspicion on his face. "You hardly had time to do anything. Don't tell me you brought in clones to do all the work again."

"Huh? No, no, definitely not." Alpha waves his hand flippantly, brushing Harold's concerns off. "I created a new dimension, put the Volgrim there temporarily and... destroyed Melkin. Just like I said I would. After that, the Kolvaxians fled in different directions. I destroyed a few of their ships, but most of them got away."

Cassiel and Samantha stare at him in stunned silence. After a moment, Cassiel is the first to collect her thoughts. "You destroyed the planet? Why?! Surely you could have-"

"I could have done a lot of things, Cassiel. I've tackled Kolvaxians in many ways, but total destruction is the most effective." Alpha rubs his back and stretches, yawning the whole time. "Besides, it's just a planet. There are plenty of other ones. Since the Kolvaxians are here, my top priority is to send out drones to scope out the galaxy, and once that's done, I'll know the extent of their corruption and how far they've spread."

"But... that was their homeworld..." Cassiel trails off and looks away, unable to protest. *I guess he knows better than me*, her eyes say.

Alpha, apparently satisfied with her backing down, continues. "I'm not going to bring clones in just yet. First I need to report to Marie. She'll know how to divert our resources as needed." He looks at Harold pointedly. "I could just make more clones, but you know what that means."

Harold simply nods, as does Helen, sharing a secret they keep between themselves.

Samantha decides to ask. "Why can't he make more clones?"

"It's not that Alpha can't, it's that it's very... inadvisable. There are risks with every clone made, but creating several en-masse is extra worrisome. Better to work with what we've got." Helen says, as she nods sagely.

Her husband continues. "The fewer time-jumpers, th'better the stability of the multiverse. And less people ta' point fingers at if somethin' goes wrong." He waggles his finger as if that explains everything.

"Oh, okay." Samantha drops the subject, her curiosity satiated.

Jason Alpha rubs his arms. "What a pain. Satan got away, Kolvaxians appeared, and then there's that other Source universe that appeared recently. I'll have my hands full for the foreseeable future if this shit keeps up."

Remembering what Samantha was talking about earlier, I quickly jump to my feet. "Oh! That's right! Samantha has a theory about how Satan is able to hide from your thoughtsmithing!"

"What, really?" Alpha is unconvinced, but he turns to face her anyway. "You have a theory? That's surprising."

"Thanks for the vote of confidence," Samantha mumbles.

Several minutes pass as she explains her theory to him about Satan bodyshifting. Alpha's sharper than the rest of us, and quickly gleans the needed details before she even finishes.

"Damn. That's smart. I dunno why, but it never occurred to me. Of course Wordsmithing can already erase someone from the universe, so he must be altering his energy signature, face, true name, and everything else when he changes form. The problem is, I've never seen him as Asmodeus before. Even if I had, once I jump over to him, he can jump away and change to something completely new. It's damn near perfect for countering Locate."

Harold nods. "Might be better'n anti-energy, th' way I see it."

Alpha paces back and forth slowly. "I need a better way to track him. I've tried bugging him before, but he's too sharp. He always keeps a careful eye on me, and the bugs fail. Not to mention he's always good about reading my mind, just as I am about reading his. Neither of us is good at surprising the other... except for this body-swapping crap."

"Uh..." I tentatively grunt out a rebuttal. "Actually, while you were fighting Satan... I managed to attach a bug to him. I wanted to tell which of the clones was the real one, but it might be possible to track him using my bug."

"What? Seriously?! Why didn't you say anything sooner?" Alpha scowls at me as if I were a child in need of an ass-whipping. "The trouble you could've saved me!"

"I kinda thought the almighty thoughtsmith had the tracking thing on lock." I try to keep the snideness out of my voice, but based on how he wrinkles his nose, I'm not successful.

"Great. Well, if you're able to track Satan, that makes my job easy. Come with me. I'm going to visit the Maries, and I might as well bring you along for an introduction. We need to find out who -and what- you are." His eyes narrow. "I especially need to find out if you're Hope."

"I'm not Hope. Don't be stupid." I return his subtle glare. "Anyway, maybe I don't wanna go. You're not the boss of me."

"Technically, I am. I can erase you pretty easily, kid." Alpha casually pulls back and examines his nails, like a prima donna. "You should come along for your own sake. It'll be a nice learning experience."

Cassiel and Samantha suddenly look worried, but I quickly put their fears to rest. "Fine, fine. I'll go. Is this going to take long?"

"Maybe, maybe not. Doesn't matter. We'll be back in a flash from their perspective." He beckons at Cass and Sam. "The bed probably won't even have time to cool."

"You're crude," Samantha snarks. "I don't know what series of events it took to create you, but you're also kinda... cold."

"You'd be surprised what a billion years can do to a person's social niceties," Alpha counters. "Anyway, when you spend every waking hour saving the multiverse, you can play the part of the polite galactic hero. I just do what needs to be done. That's all."

Alpha turns away and pulls Harold and Helen aside to whisper conspiratorial things, leaving Sam, Cass and I alone.

"Are you going with him?" Cassiel asks.

I nod. "Not much of a choice. Besides, it sounds like time is relative when you're... traveling. We'll leave and then reappear, and you won't even know we were gone."

Samantha leans against Cassiel and sulks. "If you say so."

"C'mon, Sam. Don't be like that! I'll be back in a jiffy."

"Uh huh."

She continues to sulk, and Cassiel wraps her arm around Sam comfortingly, leaving me out of their exchange. Samantha looks away, but Cassiel keeps staring at me. "I don't trust Alpha."

"Why not?"

"Something's off about him. I thought he was a little dumb at first, but it's not that." Cassiel shoots a quick glance at the other me, but he completely ignores us to talk with Helen and Harold. "Everything he does is deliberate. I can't see a billion-year-old person, whether he's technically 'you' or not, as an idiot. It might be an act."

"Or it might not," Samantha counters. "Satan and I are pretty old too, year-wise. After a while, age stops being a factor in personality. People don't change as they get older; they cement into their ways."

"Nothing about the mind is rigid," Cassiel replies calmly. The two of them continue their back and forth, embracing each other, but holding a somewhat intense battle of philosophy, which progressively moves further and further from where it first started.

Alpha appears at my side. "Okay! We're ready to go, buddy!" I nearly jump out of my fucking skin again. He's a goddamned ninja.

"Uh. Okay. Just one more minute." I quickly push past Alpha and run over to hug Samantha and Cass. Pulling them close, I ignore their little debate and kiss each of them quickly, then pull

away, noticing they no longer care about what they were discussing. "I love both of you. We'll be back sooner than you know, okay?"

"Love you too," Cassiel says, though she suddenly chokes up at the words. She's not one to be all emotional at goodbyes. Strange.

"Yeah, same, love." Samantha slinks over and pecks me on the cheek. "Make sure you come back, or that's the last taste of these lips you'll get."

"Trust me; I wouldn't leave either of you behind even if my life depended on it." I quickly walk away and return to Alpha's side. "Let's go. Make it snappy."

He nudges me and winks. "What, you don't want a quickie for the road? Jeez, man. It'll be maybe a couple hours for them, but it might be a week or two for you. Don't want any pent-up frustration when you see Marie in her tight labcoat."

I glare viciously at him. "I've seen it. Didn't do anything for me. Now shut up and let's get going."

"Okay, okay! Don't say I didn't warn you." Alpha beckons to Harold and Helen, and as they walk up, he waves at Cassiel and Sam. "Okay you two, I'll borrow your boyfriend. Cya soon!"

"Bye, Jas-" Samantha starts to wave, and a second later, she's gone.

Uh, what?"

It takes me a second to realize my surroundings have changed. Axis Mundi is gone.

Whipping my head around, I quickly try to reorient myself. A giant, empty room, with metal plated walls, floor, and ceiling, along with a bunch of fluorescent lights. Only the four of us are here, nobody else.

Alpha scratches his nose. "Was that the first time someone else has teleported you?"

I nod. "Yeah."

"Now you know how everyone else feels. Welcome to the Central Hub." Alpha smiles at me, and an odd glowing feeling fills my body. This place is special; it exists outside the multiverse. Only a Wordsmith who's been here before can find it. Just a few people in all the universes have likely seen the place before, and they were all probably-

"Take off your clothes," Alpha says, as he continues to smile at me creepily. "You need to be decontaminated."

Uh. What.

Part 481c: The Central Hub

"Take your clothes off," Jason Alpha says, a weird smile on his face. "You need to be decontaminated."

A cold drop of sweat runs down my back. "Are... are you serious?" I suppose stripping down in front of myself isn't shameful or anything, but... Helen's watching...

Shrugging, I grumble silently to myself and start to unbuckle my belt, only for Harold to burst out laughing. "Haw! The son of a gun was about ta' do it!"

Alpha's body trembles as he holds a laugh in, but Harold's chortling puts him over the edge. "Pft! I can't believe you fell for that. Oldest joke in the book!"

My cheeks burn, and I quickly put my buckle back on. Helen looks away, trying not to make eye contact.

"Funny," I mutter.

The men laugh and slap their knees for a solid minute straight while I turn my back to them, silently plotting my revenge. It doesn't take long for my eyes to start roving around. The room is illuminated by lights in the ceiling, but aside from the bulbs, nothing else is in the room with us. The floor is made of tiled metal panels, perhaps two-by-two, all slapped together that form a series of squares which stretch out to the edges of the room. I wonder privately why Alpha would teleport here of all places. What's the point of an empty room?

Alpha and Harold finally stop laughing and regain their senses. Harold pokes me in the back. "It was just a joke, kid! Don't get all bothered by it!"

"I'm not annoyed. I'm just wondering what this room is for, if not decontamination."

I turn back to face them, and Alpha wipes away his last tear of laughter. "Oh, this place? It's the Arrival Point. When you're dealing with time travelers, and the worrying possibility that Satan or someone else could find it, you have to take several precautions."

He doesn't elaborate, so I nod expectantly. "Like?"

A pause. Alpha rubs his forehead slowly. "Well, for one thing, there are several levels of confidentiality involved with news of the future, past, things like that. It's need-to-know, and you don't need to know just yet."

From behind, the sound of metal grinding makes me flinch and jerk my head around. A slat in the ceiling and a camera pops out and evaluates us. Marie's voice squawks from an unseen loudspeaker. "Visit number?"

Harold takes a step toward the camera. "Ahh, it's about one four nine, six three three, one four two."

"About?" Marie's analytical voice pops out a single word. "Is it 'about' that number, or exactly that number?"

"Exactly," Alpha says, cutting Harold off. "What coordinate have we arrived at?"

The camera stares at us silently for several moments before Marie replies. "Looks like it's been about three thousand years since the last coordinate. I'm pulling up the files now." It takes a few seconds, but she coughs audibly before the camera shifts slightly to look at me. "Is this the variant you detailed the last time you were here?"

"Yup." Alpha keeps his reply short.

"So no identifier? Make sure he knows the rules before you enter."

"I will," Alpha promises. He reaches over and grabs my shoulder. "He's one of the good guys!"

"If you say so." Marie doesn't sound convinced. Her camera menacingly leans forward, almost shoving into my face. "You'll be under 64/5 surveillance while you're here. No funny business."

"No funny business," I echo, while wondering to myself, *what's 64/5 about?*

Without another word, the camera retracts, lifts back up into the ceiling, and the slat closes behind it. The sound of rumbling at the other side of the room draws my attention. When I look in its direction, I flinch as a doorway suddenly appears. A wall panel I hadn't noticed, roughly 8 feet tall and three wide, slides to the side, revealing a mystery area outside.

Alpha grunts under his breath. "Don't talk to anyone. If you do, they'll just ignore you. Also, stay close. There's anti-energy everywhere in this facility, and the potency of it is a million times worse than anything you've seen in your short life."

The four of us start trudging toward the door. "Why so much anti-energy?"

"Protection, Sparky." Alpha pauses at the doorway and looks up at the ceiling. "Imagine if Satan found this place. We'd want to be able to kill him the instant he arrived, and at a minimum prevent him from collapsing the dimen- Marie! Marie! You forgot the bracelets!" Alpha interrupts himself to howl at the ceiling. "Why am I reminding you of this? It's always me who forgets!"

Her voice sounds off once more. "I was... just testing you. Yes, that's what it was. You passed." Another panel opens in the ceiling, and Alpha holds his palm above his head, allowing four blue bracelets to land perfectly in his grasp.

He lowers his hand and grumbles again. "Testing me, my ass. I leave for a few thousand years, and you bums... mumble-mumble..." He trails off, and I don't catch the rest of it. After a few seconds, he presses two of the bracelets into Harold and Helen's hands, then stares at one of the two remainders before lightly tossing it to me. I catch it and note the glowing letters on its screen. *Sparky*. Funny.

As I attach my bracelet, I glance at his. *Big Dawg 4162*, it reads. *Is he serious?* Harold's and Helen's simply display their names, plus a string of digits similar to Alpha's. I wonder what the numbers stand for.

Finally, he pushes forward, and I follow after him, Harold and Helen behind me. Immediately, a sense of *volume* hits me, as if we've gone from a sensory deprivation chamber to the streets of Chicago. We enter a giant room that vaguely reminds me of a high-tech shopping mall, or like the New York Stock Exchange that I remember from before I entered the cryopod. Rows of computer screens hang down from the ceiling, each one displaying a vast array of technical data that makes my head spin. Elevators rise and fall, but they seem to ride on cushions of air, and are sealed inside tubes.

Helen helpfully points to them and says, "Hovershafts." They look pretty advanced. I suppose for a neanderthal from the industrial and computing age, anything from the future would seem sci-fi to me.

Fountains, gardens, all sorts of decorations are spread out all over the place. Several rooms, their occupants visible through soundproof glass-walls, are scattered around here and there. The room must be as wide as ten football fields. I can barely see the distant walls, which rise several hundred feet to a glass ceiling above. Up there, the soles of people's shoes are visible as they walk around on the glass, unflinching, despite how high they are. The glass looks like it could shatter all at once and everyone above would plummet to a gruesome death. I don't have much in the way of acrophobia, but even I'd be a little wary walking on that glass.

But what stuns me the most is the sheer number of people traveling around. While clumps of pedestrians stand together and talk, the majority of people just travel from place to place, barely looking at those they pass. Blinking, I notice not one, but two, three, and possibly more Maries, along with a bunch of faces I don't recognize, and occasionally a face or two that look cypasted from one person to the next. After scanning the crowd for a moment, I manage to pick out Benjamin Brown, and a few other vaguely familiar faces, but most of the people are unknown to me.

"Why are there so many Marie Beckers walking around? Who are all these people?"

Alpha politely waits, allowing me to take in the sights. "Time travel, as I've said, is very complicated. Marie and I couldn't handle the workload all by ourselves, even with clones, plus having fresh perspectives now and then is always good, so we started enlisting the help of various agents across all the different streams. Source universes tend to be an exception, but that's a bit beyond your clearance level. Pretty much everyone here will recognize me, but due to self-imposed restrictions, people are only allowed to talk with others under certain circumstances, especially when involving streams that are very similar and..." He trails off, tapping his lip. "...eh, it's boring stuff. Anyway, I need to meet with one of the top-level Maries here, and they'll probably interview you later. Don't overthink it."

He starts walking toward the crowds without waiting for a response, so I just shrug and follow him. Helen and Harold lock hands, and soon I find myself wading through the crowd. Their faces mix together in my mind, and soon I notice a person here or there staring at me curiously before quickly looking away. There's a general unspoken sentiment that I'm different from what they're used to seeing, but nobody vocalizes their thoughts.

Soft music plays from speakers all around, reminding me of elevator music, but perhaps a little more inspired. As we walk across a bridge spanning a pond in the middle of the gigantic stadium, I spot a man and woman dancing inside a room, love in their eyes.

Agents, huh? These people manage the time-stream, but they're still ordinary men and women, not robots.

After several minutes of walking, we arrive at a door with a series of buttons and sensors, and Alpha quickly starts typing codes, scanning his thumb, holding his eye open, and saying a string of nonsensical words. "The cat named Camilla jumped through the wire trap, the turtle-dove entered the last day of autumn, sixteen dwarves cooking over an open fire..."

That last part makes me curl up my lip, but I shake my head and look away. A person breaks off from the crowd and walks over to us, and I realize it's one of the Marie clones, except her hair is black instead of red, and she's wearing a bathrobe instead of something like a suit or more professional attire. It's not the sort of thing I'd expect her to wear.

"Jason Alpha? What are you up to this time?"

He shrugs. "I have to tell Marie Alpha a few things, and this guy here's an anomaly, so I've just got a bunch of work ahead of me."

She stops and stares at me for a few moments before turning back to Alpha. "Yeah, you do hate work. Well, I was just curious, that's all." She stares at me again for a moment before walking away.

I decide to offer my opinion. "The heck was that about? She's a little nosy. Dressed weird, too."

"Yup. She's not Marie, though." Alpha smirks. "The confusion is written all over your face. She's one of my clones."

"Huh?" I try not to stare at him judgmentally, but a look of disgust spreads across my face. "You made a clone of yourself, and turned him female? That's creepy, dude."

"Not really. I've done it several times before. There's a reason for all the madness around here." The door suddenly clicks audibly and opens up, and a shudder goes through my body, as if for a millisecond I were being blasted with anti-energy. Alpha stumbles slightly. "Oof, that's always jarring. Sorry for the pain, looks like you noticed it too. This is the part of the Central Hub where all the good stuff happens. Naturally, we keep it flooded with incredibly high concentrations of anti-energy. Even ordinary humans need to take pills to neutralize its effects on their body."

"Jeez. You guys take security seriously."

"Mhm. Stay close, within ten feet of me, until we're in the waiting area. If you stray too far... well, don't. Just don't."

Helen presses up to my side and locks her arm through mine. "Harold isn't affected by anti-energy, but I am, sweetheart. I hope you don't mind me staying close. Anti-energy will kill me ten times faster than it will you."

"No, it's fine, ma'am." I feel a little self-conscious having her so close, but at the same time she's like my great-great-ancestor by age, so it's not that bad.

We walk through the door, and as it closes behind us, I feel like I've entered the Twilight Zone. Space-age white walls, nondescript, line a long, narrow hallway with solid iron doors littered across from each other. The hallway curves up ahead to an unknown destination, and as Alpha walks forward, I realize the moment he moves too quickly that there's a sickness bubbling up in my stomach. I quickly pull Helen along and walk faster to match his pace. There must be a drone in the ceiling or something negating the anti-energy around him, which allows him to walk around without instantly dying. However, surrounded by anti-energy like this, I'd pity an enemy who tried to teleport away. Since we're enclosed with it surrounding us in a sphere, we couldn't make the jump even if we wanted. We're trapped.

The hall curves left, right, left, sometimes there are intersections, but unlike the mall-strip outside, nobody else walks around in these halls. It's only once we've traveled the length of several city blocks that we encounter the first Marie, a stray walking down the hall in the opposite direction we are. Her face is stern, and judging by the datapad in her hand and her

pace- nonchalant without loitering, she's going to a specific destination. The Marie nods at Alpha and ignores the rest of us, but says nothing otherwise.

A minute later, we step into 'the thick of it.' Out of nowhere, Maries spring up left and right, walking up and down the hallways, some merely crossing from one door to the next. By chance, one of them opens the door to my right, and I catch a glimpse of what's inside. A dozen monitors, a chair, and a whole bunch of gadgets I barely see at all but would be hard-pressed to describe even if I could examine them thoroughly.

Observation rooms.

That's what I'd call them. They look like rooms where each Marie can monitor places or people undisturbed. If I had to guess, I'd say they're soundproof too, for maximum isolation. Windowless, nobody else around... sounds depressing. *Who'd want to work here?*

The crowd of Maries thickens, and by now none of them even bother acknowledging Alpha's presence, let alone the rest of us. The corridor feels more constricted than it did before, so I make sure to stay close to Alpha, along with Helen.

Alpha eventually slows his pace. "We're here."

We arrive in a wider, more open room, about the size of a large hospital check-in area. Chairs and benches line the walls, but there aren't any televisions playing football or gristly old men joking around about Vietnam like I'd expect from hospitals in the time I once lived. Just a whole bunch of Maries passing through.

Alpha's shoulders relax, even as another Marie pushes past him. "Now for the fun part."

"Fun part?"

"Yup." Alpha walks over to a counter where three Maries are parked, each of them with several holographic globes, computer displays, and other assorted gadgets spread out before them. I curse silently, wishing I hadn't stuck the Crown in storage. I could pull it out and instantly understand what these devices do, but that would be a terrible idea, given the security countermeasures here. They'll probably think I'm pulling out a bomb and instantly atomize me.

Gulp.

The closest Marie at the desk flicks her eyes up to glance at Alpha before lowering them again. "Your number?"

"One four nine, six three three, one four two," Alpha says.

"Uh huh. Purpose of your visit?" This Marie looks very unamused. I notice a streak of yellow going through her red hair, though. A way to distinguish herself from the others? Every Marie I've seen so far, barring Alpha's clone in the bathrobe, wears the same generic business suit or

lab-coat, as if to designate their workspaces. Aside from that, they all look identical. When Alpha called his clones to fight Satan, those guys looked and acted unique from one another, as if they were doing so deliberately to send a message. Marie, however, seems fine with all of her copies looking and acting the same.

"I'm here to see Marie Alpha."

"Mmm." Receptionist Marie goes quiet for several seconds as if she's completely tuned us out. While she taps on the screen, occasionally glancing to her side to check some readout I can't see, Alpha flashes a smile at me. "She's determining clearance levels and a bunch of other stuff. It's boring stuff."

He sure loves calling everything boring, my mind mutters.

Seconds turn into minutes. I tap my foot impatiently as we wait, but Alpha just stares blankly at the Marie, almost looking through her. He's probably reminiscing about some past event or whatever. All the while, he rubs the ring on his hand, pulling it slightly off, then back on again, over and over. Without a rush of things to do, I casually examine the golden band. It has a tiny jewel inset, probably diamond, given its white color. The ring is very dull otherwise, but with a start, I realize it resembles the three archangel rings I'm wearing.

"Hey." I reach over and poke Alpha's shoulder. "That ring of yours... is there anything special about it?"

Alpha blinks and his eyes refocus as he returns to reality. "Huh? What? This?" An embarrassed expression floods his face as he sticks his hand in his pocket. "Oh, uh, it's nothing. It belonged to an old friend of mine. She gave it to me when she... well... never mind. It's boring stuff." He turns his head away, uninterested in continuing the conversation.

I wonder if the ring belonged to an archangel once, my mind whispers questioningly.

"Okay, we're all set." The receptionist speaks up, startling me. I forgot she even existed for a moment. "She'll see you in four hours, thirty-four minutes and sixteen seconds."

"Wow, she's bringing the hustle this time," Alpha says, as he whistles slowly. "Last time I had to wait three days."

"She is a very busy woman," the receptionist Marie says. Her tone is bland enough that I can almost taste depression. "Take a seat."

Wordlessly, Alpha beckons for me to follow, Helen pulls away from me and steps back to her husband. "There's no anti-energy in this room, so we'll part ways here. Try not to weep, cutie, but I'll hang on my husband, now."

"Darn," I say, smiling politely at her. She's a funny lady. "I'm the loser in this situation."

"Tootin' straight," Harold says, as he rubs his wife's back. "You got two of your own, kid! This one's my lady! Pahaha!"

The four of us wander over to the benches and sit down. Despite all the Maries going in and out of the waiting area, some to a pair of giant double doors on the opposite side of the reception desk, others to different doors and rooms elsewhere, not a single Marie ever sits down and waits. It's as if I'm watching lemmings traveling around from one place to the next. Why even build this giant waiting area? Do they get tons of visitors sporadically?

Harold and Helen start whispering to each other, and I don't bother to eavesdrop. Alpha leans back in his seat and sighs, then pulls another chair closer and kicks his feet up on it.

"Better get comfy. It'll be a while."

I don't take him up on his offer, and instead just lean back against the wall, silently watching the stream of Maries walking past. Just how many are here? A thousand? Several thousand? Why are so many necessary?

Time travel. Not just time travel, but multiverses. I'm not a complete idiot; I can take stabs in the dark at how they might work. There are a few theories I read, years ago. One of them is the idea of infinite universes... for every possibility, every choice we make, every random collision of atoms, there exists another universe where a different outcome occurs. One universe might have me defeat Diablo in combat, while in another I miss just slightly with my final blow and the battle ends in a stalemate, but then there's also my universe where I get beat down like a little bitch, and an infinite number of permutations in between.

Infinite universes... unlikely. I'd say, based on how Alpha reacted when he met me, and how he considers me an aberration, that there must be a finite number of universes.

If that's the case, then the other option is that time travel is what creates a new universe. If I travel back in time and kill a young Adolf Hitler, then a new universe will be created, one where he lives, and one where he dies. After all, if I kill him early, then that would create a paradox, since in the future I travel from, my reason for going back in time would change, and I probably wouldn't go back. The fact that the multiverse exists at all and that Alpha has suggested time travel is dangerous must mean the two are linked.

So if time travel creates new universes, what are the rules and restrictions? Could I grab a sports almanac from 40 years in the future, travel back to my current time, and simply live out a new life where I become an eccentric billionaire? Does traveling to the future create a new universe?

Hell, maybe they aren't linked in the way that I think. Maybe it isn't time travel that creates new universes. Perhaps time travel just jumps you from one universe to the next. What if I skip

from an exact moment in time in my universe to an identical one in a different universe? Does time travel include universe hopping? Can I move between the universes at will?

Shit, then there's the question of the universes themselves. Do they vary dramatically? Alpha said the Kolvaxians were limited to just one universe, or 'stream,' or whatever... so is that universe different from my own? Maybe it's identical, except for the fact the Kolvaxians exist. Maybe people in the Kolvaxian universe have four arms and legs, and they can shoot web from their butts and crawl on walls like spiders.

Well, every human I've seen so far looks like I'd expect. I haven't seen one that falls far off the bell curve of acceptable dimensions. Then again, they might be keeping the weird ones in a laboratory somewhere. Given what Cassiel told me about Marie, I can imagine her making freakish Chimera monsters out of little girls and dogs, just to see if it's possible.

"You okay?" Alpha's voice makes me flinch in surprise. I was so lost in thought that I was off in la-la land. "You've been staring at the receptionist for five minutes straight. It's kinda creepy."

"I am? I mean, I was?" I quickly look away as blood rushes to my cheeks. "Uh, I was lost in thought. Just thinking about time travel and how it works."

Alpha turns away. "Cool." He doesn't say anything else, which feels a little rude.

"We're going to be here a few hours. Why not just explain to me how time travel works?"

"It's boring stuff." He shrugs and continues to face left, away from me. "And dangerous. We try to minimize the number of Travelers as much as possible. If you never time travel in your life, the multiverse will be better for it."

"Why?"

He turns back, a look of irritation on his face. "Whaddya mean, 'why?' Awful things can happen. I learned that the hard way."

Helen and Harold's conversation dies down, and I feel their gaze on my back. Still, I press him. "Can't you tell me, even in the vaguest terms, what happened?"

Alpha stares coldly into my eyes. "I had to exterminate an entire universe. It was the only way to be certain."

"Y-you what?!" My mouth flops open. Shock surges through me. "How- no, why? That seems excessive!"

"Yeah. Excessive." Slowly, Alpha licks his lips. "You remember your little pet Sentinel? The one Satan stole when he left?"

"Mhm." I swallow and realize I'm probably not ready for what he's about to say.

"Before the Kolvaxians, there was a different threat to the multiverse. It was entirely my fault. I thought I could just go back in time and save a woman I cared for, but in the process, I accidentally leaked information to the Volgrim. When they awakened the Sentinels, those robots learned of the existence of the multiverse, and that I could destroy them. They spread apart, rather than bunching together, and began to build an army of millions. We didn't realize until it was almost too late. Once we found out, the Sentinels launched their assault, and nearly gained access to one of Marie's beacons- the ones that allow her variants to travel from the Central Hub to each universe."

Alpha's lips dry up like an apple in the middle of the desert. "I had seconds, just a few precious seconds to come up with a plan. Given the options at my disposal, which were basically none, I opted to use the failsafe. I collapsed the entire universe, killing every soul in every galaxy across the entire span of its cosmos. Not only did I destroy those Sentinels, I also killed our agents, septillions of innocents, and the woman I loved. Ironical. I went back in time to save her life, and ended up killing her instead."

He turns to stare at the crowd of Maries cycling through the room. "I will never forget."

It takes me a moment to form a response. "Why not just collapse the Milky Way? That's still, you know, all of humanity, the Volgrim, etcetera... but still."

"Wouldn't work. I had to assume the Sentinels may have entered unseen dimensions, were outside the Milky Way, and may have even reached other galaxies. There was only one choice I could make at that moment." He shakes his head and slouches back in the chair, slowly sagging down until he's looking at the ceiling. "I learned about cause and effect because of that, and we devised many of the protection systems that you've seen already. Those include the confidentiality system, clearance levels, and even how this place is flooded with anti-energy. I realized how devastating it would be if Satan or a Sentinel made it into the Central Hub, and how much damage they could cause." Alpha smiles grimly. "They could destroy the multiverse, you know. They could destroy everything."

A long minute passes as neither of us says anything.

"Alpha, if you can collapse an entire universe..." I pause, realizing the significance of what I'm about to ask. "...then... does that mean Satan can, as well?"

He coughs. "Don't ask questions you don't want the answer to."

Oh god. That means *yes*.

Alpha closes his eyes. "Just shut up for a while, Sparky. This topic is boring. Time travel is boring. I hate it."

I nod, while staring at a clock on the wall. *Four hours, twenty-four minutes left. He's given me a lot to think about.*

I tilt my head to the right, and my eyes meet Helen's. She quickly lowers her gaze. "Don't judge him harshly, dear. You don't know what he's been through."

I nod slightly. *She's right. I don't.*

Sighing, I close my eyes. *Maybe he has the right idea. I should just take a catnap.*

Part 482c: Paralysis

My eyes close, but I can't sleep. I don't need to, anymore, but I remember a time when I once did. At some point, the spiritual energy in my body started giving me so much vitality that sleep became impossible. Still, I close my eyes for a short time and remember my past. All the struggles, trials, and tribulations. All the friends I've lost, and the enemies I've killed. They don't matter. None of it matters. If I want to see someone, I can just find a stream where they still exist. Will they be the same person I once knew?

Of course not. The difference between me from an hour ago and me right now might as well be the same as each iteration of my clones. My former self ceases to exist, and a new one takes his place, minute after minute, second after second, constantly replacing the old one.

So, in the end, maybe I haven't lost anyone at all. They still exist, just in different forms. The problem is that I can't look at them the same, treat them the same, or pretend to myself that they aren't different from how I remember. That's probably just because of my human psyche.

"Jason Alpha." Marie's voice to my left pulls me from my thoughts. I blink and turn my head slightly to look at her. She's one of the couriers, so not high up on the totem pole, but still highly intelligent. There isn't a 'stupid' Marie anywhere in here.

"Yep. Is it already that time?"

"Correct. Marie Alpha is ready to see you." Her eye flicks to my right as she evaluates Sparky. "Is that Jason coming along? I don't have him on the appointment roster."

I glance over at him, following her gaze, and shake my head. He's deep asleep, probably exhausted from his encounter with the Kolvaxians and all the chaos over the last twenty-four hours, from his perspective, of course.

"No. It's just me. He's a variant, one the Psyops division is going to evaluate." I stand up and turn to face her. "Lead the way."

Without replying, the courier Marie turns on a dime and starts marching to the double-doors across the room, opposite where we were sitting on the benches. Several Maries from the R&D division are in the halls today, maybe they've got a day off or something. I don't understand how each Marie can be so similar to one another, especially considering my clones go to such great lengths to differentiate themselves from each other, and me. Perhaps she's more of a collectivist, while I'm an individualist. Either way, she's still smarter than me, so maybe she knows something I don't. She's an awful lot like Satan, in that way.

I follow along, and soon the hallway becomes a blur as the inner sanctum flies by. The atmosphere is much tenser in here, and far fewer Maries roam the halls. Of all the sections, the Temporal Alignment Division is the highest classification level. Even Maries in the same room aren't allowed to share information with each other regarding each timeline. Marie Alpha says this is because even she can make mistakes, but I'm not sure about that.

Finally, we arrive at an ornate wooden door. The courier stops in front of it. "I've brought your visitor." Her voice transmits through a microphone into the room past the door, and after a few moments, a gruff voice responds.

"Yes, yes. Let him in already."

The courier steps in front of the keypad, blocks it from my view, and types a 45 digit password on the console. Even I'm not allowed to know keys unless necessary. It's fine; I'm the muscle, not the brains. I leave the heavy thinking to Marie.

The wooden door silently slides open and the courier nods. Without saying goodbye, she turns and leaves from the way she came. *Here goes*, I think to myself. *Talking to Marie Alpha is always a pain, but an immortal demigod's gotta do what he's gotta do.*

The room, as always, smells of dirt and plants. Vines hang from the ceiling, and the lighting in the room is dull compared to the harsh neon lights from outside. A gut-wrenching cough sounds off from Marie Alpha as I enter, making me flinch even though I can't see her behind her monitors. "Kah! Took you long enough. You've wasted fourteen minutes and thirty-four seconds getting here!"

"Sorry, Marie." I apologize, as always, and the door closes behind me. One of her lizards hisses from its aquarium-like container, and I stick my tongue out at it. She loves them, to be sure. The room has several dozen of the little buggers in glass containers all embedded in the walls, along with snakes, and an automated system for breeding bugs and dropping them inside. Their habitats have sticks, tiny trees, and all sorts of odd plants she's collected from various planets. The multiverse is ripe with life, but most of it is plantlike, not sentient.

I hear that familiar humming sound as her hoverchair hums to life, levitates, and she floats around her desk to face me. Like always, her body is unable to move, but she never accepts anyone's help with repairing it. I could heal a broken neck easily enough, and even the medical division could work miracles. For her, though, it's a reminder of the time she underestimated a Wordsmith. Her long grey hair and sagging skin show not only how old she is, but how she once lived in a stream before nanobots existed that could keep a person looking young and beautiful forever. Her looks are easily fixable with Wordsmithing, but that pride of hers...

Her head leans to the left slightly, but she quickly jerks her chair by tapping a button to re-orient her head. She's good at catching herself. "You're looking worse for wear." Her eyes jerk to my right shoulder. "There's dirt on your jacket."

"You look like shit too. Still can't beat me at ping-pong." Most people wouldn't give her any crap about her disability, but in my opinion, she chose to stay in a hoverchair, so it's fair game. Besides, even the other Maries walk on eggshells around her. If I don't poke some fun, who will? "I was busy fighting Kolvaxians. It takes more effort than most other things I do."

She smiles slightly, but it almost instantly fades as a look of concern replaces it. "Kolvaxians? I thought you were going back to investigate that Jason variant you mentioned. Why did you detour to 10K?"

Oh boy. Here it comes. "I didn't. The Kolvaxians have infested a new universe. My Source universe, to be exact."

"I see. That's... unfortunate." Marie doesn't pause or flinch at my words, almost as though she couldn't care less. I know better. "How long ago did the infestation begin?"

"I haven't looked into it yet, since we only just found out. After I fought the Kolvaxians, I brought Helen, Harold, and the Jason I reported on straight here. From what little I gleaned from the Volgrim survivors, it's been in the range of several million years."

Finally, her blank facade cracks. "A few million- what?! Your Source universe has been infested for that long, and nobody noticed?!"

The guilt is written all over my face. "We had Helen there monitoring the situation, but since she wasn't in touch with the Volgrim at all, she didn't know that they were warring against the Kolvaxians. I doubt the Volgrim realized what they were up against. From what I've heard, the parasites went incognito for a long time, spread their influence across the galaxy, then began their assault on the Volgrim out of nowhere."

Marie squints, which is her way of nodding. "Any guesses about the infection rate?"

There's a marble in my throat. "I can't be certain, but it's probably worse than 10K's progress."

"Oh." Her tone is hollow. "And how did they get to the Source in the first place?"

A question I can answer. "That would be my fault."

"Come again?"

This is going to suck. "Uhm. You probably don't remember, but-"

"I remember everything." Marie says, as she glares at me.

"Right. Well, when I destroyed Volgarius, the one from my Source universe, I may have broken a few quantum mechanics."

A long pause follows as she digests the information.

"You slammed a meteor made of solid, ultra-dense iron into the planet. If I remember correctly, it was traveling at low-warp speeds. Is that correct?"

I nod. "Yeah. I believe it may have ripped a hole in space-time. If I'm correct, the Kolvaxians probably traversed the multiverse to arrive there."

Marie flinches visibly. "Fucking idiot. It's unlikely the rip would connect to 10K alone. It may have allowed them to arrive in other universes and streams stealthily. This blunder could be a catastrophe, unlike anything we've ever faced before. You always screw everything up."

"Uh, eh-heh..." I chuckle weakly at her stinging insults, but they're just words, after all. "I was still young, Marie. Accidents happen."

"Spilling wine on your suit is an accident. Don't deflect. You broke the multiverse, so you have to fix it." She gnaws her lip for a moment before slowly turning her chair so she can stare at her lizards. She's told me in the past that they help her think. "For once, I'm stumped. We have just enough resources to keep the multiverse maintained. We have barely enough personnel to fight the Kolvaxians in a single universe, let alone the entire goddamn multiverse. How are we supposed to combat them?"

"I could just make more clones?"

"If that option were on the table, we'd have done it already. You know what more wordsmiths mean just as well as I do. More leaks. A higher likelihood of slipups. A greater chance of causality errors. The problem is that wordsmiths and thoughtsmiths are the only beings that can fight the Kolvaxians on equal terms."

She's always so pessimistic. "I disagree. A coalition of forces, made up of humans, demons, angels and Volgrim could fight the Kolvaxians. You should pour more resources into diplomacy, ensuring everyone gets along with each other so they can all combat the Kolvaxians as a combined military force."

Marie coughs. "Kuh. You think it's that simple? Every single universe is embroiled in conflict. Not one has managed peace among all four sentients, and several have exterminated one or more of them. In your Source universe alone, the angels are nearly extinct. In the L-series, demons are hanging on by a thread."

"We don't need all four sentient species to exist across the multiverse. If the four sentients can combine their forces in as many universes as possible, we could use my clones to shore up

weaknesses in the universes and streams lacking a species."

She pauses to consider my idea. "I guess that's conceivable. Still, making everyone get along will be damn near- wait." A pause. She turns around and hovers over to her desk, then slightly moves her finger to tap a button on her chair arm and activate her mental interface with the computer. A minute passes. "Ah. Here it is. I meant to talk to you about this particular stream anyway. Do you recall the last time we spoke?"

I nod. "It was only a year ago for me. Why?"

"I told you about one of the universes that we had designated a Source universe. The Jason of that universe was not one of your clones. The Marie stationed there mollified him, and together they embarked on quite the journey. She was, eventually, able to force peace between all four sentients."

"What? She was? How?" I'm fairly surprised. "I thought you said no universe has ever managed that before."

"Mmm. Well, I say 'unified,' but it's only in a technical sense. Angels and humans get along quite well, the Volgrim are mostly neutral, and the demons are pacified. It's not like they're singing and dancing, but there isn't any war. That's a good first step."

"Yeah." I stare at the old woman for a few moments, several thoughts swimming around in my mind. "So, it sounds like you want to model other systems after hers? That could take a while."

Marie taps a button on her chair, and a mechanical hand drops down from the ceiling holding a cigarette, already lit. With a practiced movement, she turns her chair slightly and allows the hand to slip the fogey in her mouth and retract, then she inhales and exhales, all within five seconds. "It will. However, I want you to go to that universe, personally. This universe, as I've said, is probably the second Source. You've heard my theories on Source universes, so you know what that means."

I can already hear the alarm bells in my head. "Another *Rewinder*."

"Most likely. However, you've mentioned the other Jason you found in your Source universe. That would make for three Sources, across two universes, but there's a problem. There's a fourth Source."

"You're fucking with me."

"No. I'm not." Another long inhale, and the cigarette lights up visibly. Of all the Maries, she's the only one who smokes these days, and she does it despite the fact she instituted the no-smoking rule. Selfish as ever, I suppose. "Recently, it has come to my attention that Marie 12F,

the one in charge of the second Source universe, was forced to retreat to the Central Hub. She gave the Temporal Council a disturbing account of a new Jason who appeared from nowhere. He arrived in a Cryopod, and his personality was decidedly... unhinged. Thanks to 12F's ingenuity, we were able to acquire a record of his memories. He's killed already, brutally."

"Brutally," I say, repeating the word. "You make it sound like there's already a theory going around about him."

She squints at me. "We've designated him 'Jason X,' but I believe he may be Hope."

Confusion. Uncertainty. A few distinct sensations bubble up like acid under my skin. "I haven't told you about the Jason I found in my Source universe yet. I thought that perhaps *he* was Hope. Now you're telling me this new one is, so what does that make the one I found?"

"I don't know. There are now potentially four Source Jasons, including yourself." The mechanical hand descends from the ceiling and pulls the cigarette from her mouth, just in time too, given it was about to burn her lip. She releases it at the last possible moment, and the arm drops the butt into a receptacle before retracting again. "You know as well as I do how dangerous Hope is."

Hope is scary. A funny sentence, under most circumstances. "Surely Satan is the more dangerous threat, or even the Kolvaxians. I can kill a mere wordsmith easily. Even if Jason X unlocks thoughtsmithing, I've killed Satan's clones hundreds of times. I think you've overestimating the danger he poses."

"Better to overestimate and preemptively nuke the motherfucker than let him snap my neck a second time." Marie spits the words at me, showing she still holds to the promise she made when we first met. *Until I find and kill Hope for what he did to me, I will never fully heal.* "A single wordsmith can likely collapse the entire multiverse. It's just luck Satan hasn't done so yet. That's one reason I consider Hope a greater threat than Satan. The First Emperor is an intelligent being, one who understands concepts like risk and reward. He values self-preservation. Hope, however, is unhinged. He's a lunatic. If he were to discover the existence of the multiverse, he'd probably try to take it over, or destroy it. He's a rogue element we can't take a chance with."

Eh, maybe she's right. Admittedly, Satan makes my stomach flip-flop when I think of the damage he could do, yet doesn't. Sometimes I wonder what his goals are. Does he still lust for revenge? Does he even care about the past anymore? Honestly, his clones appear, cause a little trouble to draw my attention, then get pulverized or flee, but they never cause major catastrophes. Indeed, the Kolvaxians are much more of a threat to the multiverse than Satan, at least given his past actions.

What if I left him alone? Could we form a truce? Is it too much to ask, putting aside our differences?

...No. That can never happen. Not because of Satan, but because of me. I hate him. It's irrational, and I know that, but I still do. He killed Amelia, and when she came back, nothing was the same between us. He genocided all of my clones on that fateful day, then fled and hid. I thought he was dead for a long time until I put the pieces together and realized he must have faked his death. He's always one step ahead, toying around with the lives of people I care about, playing like he's the Creator.

I can't forgive Satan. Not after everything he's done. It would take something incredible to change that.

"Fine. You want me to go to the other Source universe. That all?"

"Not quite. You have a list of objectives you need to accomplish. First, Jason 12F, the second Source, went missing. Jason X stated that he killed Jason 12F, but the memory files Marie 12F recovered don't corroborate that story. He defeated Jason 12F, and put him inside a crystal and handed him over to Yama."

"Yama, huh? He's a tough demon to pin down. I think I've seen him maybe three times across the multiverse."

A lizard chitters in its cage, and Marie rolls over to it, presses a button on her chair to release it, and lets the little reptile crawl onto her shoulder. "Mmm. Anyway, if possible, we would like you to recover Jason 12F's body to determine if he's still alive, and investigate Jason X. If he's a threat, do what you must. Don't hesitate. Beyond that, you have the usual directives."

"What about the Jason I brought along with me? What should I do with him?"

She grunts. "I don't know. After everything I've told you, do you think he's Hope?"

"Not really."

The lizard, a chameleon by the looks of it, stares at me inquisitively. A small pain appears in Marie's eyes, as if she wishes she could stroke its head or something, but the expression passes. "Well, perhaps you should take him with you. We'll perform a psych evaluation on him, and if he's clean, bring him along. I can't think of anybody better to keep an eye on him besides you."

I turn to face the door. "Fine. Make your interrogation quick. It's kinda weird you'd want him to come along with me. Isn't that a little dangerous?"

"Leaving him in his universe is much more dangerous. We can't spare any other Jasons to assist him, and if the Kolvaxians get their hands on him-" Marie stops mid-sentence, worry in her eyes. "Well, let's take every precaution so they don't. We can afford to lose a universe to the

Kolvaxians. What we can't do is allow them to integrate a Wordsmith, or discover the existence of the Central Hub."

It takes me a moment to comprehend what she just said. "You want me to leave his universe undefended, and you aren't going to send anyone to assist? What the hell, Marie? That's cold, even for you. We should at least station a few Wordsmiths there and-"

"You don't get it, Jason. Like I said, if your asteroid ripped a hole in space, the odds that it would happen to enter only one universe, and that the affected universe would be the one the Kolvaxians originated in is astronomical. It's much more likely that the hole permeates all of time-space. That means the Kolvaxians may already be in *every* universe. I can't play favorites, just because the first infection we've learned about is in your original universe."

I quickly spin on my heel to face her. "You don't even know that other universes are affected! What if it's only my universe and 10K's? If we don't tackle the problem now, it'll be too late!"

"It's already too late." Marie's voice lowers. "The Volgrim were defeated in your universe. Jason 10K can't fight Kolvaxians on his own. Battling them requires a dedicated military, unified under one banner, fighting and innovating to keep the monsters on their toes. Since your Source universe lacks such a fighting force, dropping agents and clones in there is suicidal. I won't throw lives away for nothing."

"What about the lives the Kolvaxians are about to take if we don't help them?" I counter. "Those people, be they Volgrim, demon, or human, don't deserve to be turned. Nobody does. It's a horrible fate I wouldn't even wish upon Satan. If we don't put at least one clone there, and make them someone who's fought the Kolvaxians before, it'll be a goddamned slaughter!"

"I've made my decision," Marie says, lowering her eyes. "I'm not saying I won't send clones and agents. I just have to investigate the other universes first. First, we have to determine where in 10K they're pouring through. If it's at Volgarius Alpha's location, then it's a safe bet the same will be true of other universes. However, if they're entering through a hole located somewhere else, especially the Outer Rim, then we'll have to scour each universe. It won't be quick. Devoting resources to your Source universe preemptively will just mean that we have to risk lives in the more developed universes."

The more developed universes. Her words ring hot in my ears. "You mean your pet universes. Your projects. I know you're just toying around with some of them, Marie. Your scientific curiosity knows no boundaries."

"Don't be petty, Jason. We can argue until you turn blue in the face, but that won't change anything."

My shoulders sag. "Right. That much is obvious. I'll see you later, Marie." As I turn to walk to the door, I pause, and a smile creeps on my face. "Sorry for being such a pain in the neck."

Her glares burns holes in my back. "Fuck you."

My smile fades as the door closes behind me.

The things I do for 'peace.'

Part 483c: Disorientation

"How'd it go?"

I stare ahead blankly at the person asking the question. I'm looking at myself? No, wait, Alpha. Jason Alpha. He's asking how it went.

How *what* went? Did I do something?

I start to take a step forward, then suddenly realize I'm standing. Why am I standing? Wasn't I asleep? He went off to talk to Alpha Marie; then I dozed off. How did I get here?

Marie walks between us, then I feel the brush of another Marie's shoulder against mine, and another, and I realize I'm in the waiting area from before- that is, from when I was almost asleep, which feels like an instant ago. *What?* Evidently, the look on my face betrays my thoughts.

Alpha waves his hand in front of my eyes. "Hello? You're still Sparky, right? I didn't grab the wrong black-skinned glowing-tattooed Jason, right?"

"Me? What? Yeah. Thing? What thing did I- I went where?" My words are wrong. The order is incorrect. I don't even know what I'm saying.

Alpha nods. "Hmm. I guess they wiped your memory after the test. That makes sense. They probably leaked time travel details to you."

"They did? Who? Marie?"

Alpha nods and smiles, but shoots a glance back at Harold. "Yeah. Standard fare. They wanted to evaluate you and create a psych profile to make sure you aren't a threat to the multiverse. Can't have Satan posing as a Jason now, can we?"

"Uhh. Sure?"

An awkward silence follows. Alpha shuffles his feet slightly, before sighing. "Oookay, well, the fact they haven't thrown you in a containment unit means you're not the epitome of evil, so we should be good to go."

I slowly bob my head. "Oh, great." After arriving in this weird place and arriving in the middle of a crowd of Maries, unsure how I got here, I can't wait to go back to my home universe. This whole trip was a waste of time.

Alpha beckons for Harold and Helen to come along with us, but before they can make it the few feet from their benches over to us, one of the many Maries in the hall approaches us,

specifically Alpha. "Before you go, please check Sparky's profile and sign off on his departure forms." She hands him a datapad, and he nods, tilting it away so I can't see what's on the screen.

"Hmm. Hmm. Interesting. I see." He nods mechanically as he skims whatever she gave him to read, and I start feeling a little antsy.

"You told them my name was Sparky? Seriously? And why can't I read that? It's my profile!"

Alpha raises his eyes up from the document, meets mine, then lowers them again. "All Jasons need a designation. Most are commonly referred to by their universe identifier for short. However, in your case, you come from my Source universe, so that would be kinda clunky. As for your profile..."

Alpha's expression darkens as he reads. "Very disturbing."

"Disturbing? What the hell does it say?!"

He shakes his head slowly. "Based upon the memory files they've recovered, it seems that you..." He pauses, as if for dramatic effect. "...hate puppies. That's disgusting. You're a monster."

I stare at him for several long moments as he continues to read, all while the Marie waits patiently, not even tapping her foot. "I don't hate puppies."

"I know." He smiles. "But I had you going, didn't I?"

"You're an asshole."

"You're me, so back at'cha." With unparalleled bantering skills, he deflects my attack and immediately returns to the datapad, scribbles something on the screen with his finger, then hands it to Marie. "Thanks."

"No problem." Her dry voice grates on my ears as it has every time up to this point, and she walks away, leaving us alone.

Alpha stares at me for a few moments, a thoughtful expression on his face. "You're me."

"I know. You just said that."

He shakes his head. "No, the memories are identical. I knew your body was familiar, but it's been so long since I saw it. You have the power of the three archangels. Gabriel, Raphael, and Michael."

"Um. Yes?" His sudden pressing about my past makes me uncomfortable, especially given how lost I feel right now. "Is that a problem?"

"I wonder." He chuckles wryly. "I ended up giving those rings to someone important. I guess you got your hands on them, somehow. They're probably the same rings I once owned."

Whatever he's saying makes no sense to me at all. I remember how I obtained my rings, and that was via a battle with Bahamut. Then again, Alpha's been alive a long time. Did he give the rings to Bahamut? *Why?*

Before I can ask, Alpha continues. "Everything about you is identical to me. I don't know how you arrived in my Source universe, but seeing you reminds me of my past. I don't like that."

From what I've seen of Alpha, he smiles and jokes around here and there, but sometimes his eyes hollow out, as though he's just putting on an act. For what purpose, though? For whose benefit?

"What happened in your past?" I ask, but quickly follow up with, "Besides destroying an entire universe."

"Many things. I've done a lot I'm not proud of."

"Like what?"

"Things." Alpha turns away and gestures to Harold and Helen, who are standing beside him now. I didn't even notice them there. "They know. Being a hero doesn't always mean being a good guy. Sometimes you have to make choices, and both options are the *worst*."

"Like killing a whole universe of people?"

"Yeah. However, the choice is sometimes whether to save your best friend or the woman you love. Somehow, those events burn more than the former."

I think I get the picture. Alpha somehow was unable to save someone important to him, even with the power of Wordsmithing. It's caused him to feel resentment and anger, but he covers up those emotions with jokes and sarcasm because he still must perform his duty, even if he doesn't always want the job.

"I'm sorry things turned out like that for you."

Alpha nods. "It's in the past. Boring time travel stuff. Can't change it, can't fix it. Anyway, enough chit-chat. Let's get out of here. We've got a mission." Immediately, he starts walking toward the exit.

"A mission?" I let Helen take my arm, and we fall into line behind Alpha. "What do you mean?"

"Didn't I say? We're on a mission to investigate the second Source universe. A lot is riding on this. There is a suspicious new Jason who has appeared, and we think he might be--"

"Hold on; I didn't sign up for that!" I interrupt him before he can finish. "I thought you were bringing me here for an evaluation, then returning me to my universe. Why do I have to go with

you?"

"I want to keep an eye on you," Alpha says, without looking back. Several Maries, all clustered together, pass us in the tight corridor. "Also, you might prove to be relevant. The Jason we're investigating is probably Hope."

Hope? I repeat the name in my head. "You think he's shown up now?"

"Mhm."

"So you need me to come along... because... why?"

"Like I said, to keep an eye on you."

I scowl. "I don't need you to do that. I don't *want* you doing that. You're kinda creepy sometimes."

"It's not up for debate," Alpha says, as he suddenly stops and turns to face me. Fire burns in his eyes. "I don't know who you are, or where you came from, but there are an awful lot of coincidences surrounding you. I know it sucks being yanked away from your cute little girlfriends, but the entire goddamned multiverse is at stake."

"So you expect me to leave them behind?! What about the Kolvaxians?! Those monsters nearly tore them apart the last time we fought!" An urge to punch Alpha's stupid smug face boils up in my gut, but I resist, given he can splatter me all over the floor. It's smarter to use my words, not my fists. "You're telling me to go dawdle off for god knows how long, leaving them to fight in a warzone!"

Alpha groans. "God, how many times have I told you? That's not how time travel works! We can jump back to five minutes after we left and they'll barely even notice you were gone!"

Cautiously, I stare him down. "We can return to a point right after we left?"

"Exactly!"

A thought clicks in my head. "Doesn't that mean there's no rush to do this mission?"

"What?" Alpha's jaw slackens. "What's that supposed to mean?"

"I mean that if we can travel back to that time, then surely it works the same way for the mission. Whatever universe and time you plan to go to, we could spend a year in our source universe, then jump to the mission location and it would be the same as if we went now."

Alpha's face contorts in disbelief. "Well- I mean, that is..."

Helen squeezes my arm a little. "It isn't the same, not when we're dealing with other travelers, sweetheart. Satan is still out and about, and the Jason we're going to investigate, who might be Hope, is a big problem we can't leave unattended."

"How is it different?"

"Can't say." Helen cuts me off with two quick words, but then she turns to smile at Alpha. "You know, dear, it wouldn't hurt for us to go back to his Source universe for a day or two. Let's not be sticklers for the rules just because Marie barks an order."

I glance around and check, but no Maries are in the hallway. Somehow, given all the implied surveillance, it feels like a bad idea to insult her, but since turrets don't pop out of the walls and litter our bodies with anti-energy, we're probably okay.

Alpha rubs the top of his head and closes his eyes. "God, why do things always have to be so complicated? A single alarm about an activated Sentinel has turned into the biggest, dumbest mess of my life, and I've lived a long time!" He turns away from us to face down the corridor and quickly starts walking, so I pull Helen along and follow after him.

A minute passes, and Alpha tromps along but says nothing. Finally, he relents. "Cripes. Fine, whatever. We'll go back to your Source, you can say hi to your girlfriends, and then we're leaving. Okay?"

"Thanks, Alpha," I reply, gratitude and sincerity prime in my thoughts. He's an asshole, but he isn't impervious.

I mouth *thank you* to Helen, and she winks at me. *Alpha's not that bad, you just have to use the right words*, her expression says.

* * *

Many minutes later, we pass through the exit to the Marie section of the Central Hub, and into the Agent area, before arriving back in the room where we first started. A blank, empty void where the only visible color is white.

The door closes behind us, and Alpha taps some buttons on what looks like a smartwatch with holographic functionality. "Harold, do you have the stream synchronized?"

"Yeap, pretty much."

"Good." Something about Alpha's curt reply irks me, like he doesn't believe in Harold's ability to synchronize or something. "Once Marie drops the barrier, we'll jump."

"Hey, question." I shoot a suspicious glance at Alpha. "Last time you said you were going to come back after three days, but you returned in less than one. How reliable is your method for dating when to return?"

A drop of sweat visibly slides down Alpha's neck. "P-pretty reliable. We usually get close to the mark."

"Usually?"

Alpha quickly looks away, right as Marie's voice plays over the loudspeaker. "Jason Alpha, your exit slot is one-four-nine, six-three-three, one-four-three. We're lowering the anti-energy field now."

He exhales audibly, but I cut him off before we can jump. "Are you ignoring me?"

" **Travel!** " Ignoring my interruption, Alpha barks the word out, startling me, and a second later the room vanishes around us. A jarring transition occurs as white walls disappear and reappear as dark stone ones.

Blinking, I look around and try to reorient myself. This place is... the outpost? Yeah, the one right outside of Hero City.

It takes me another moment, but I quickly notice there's nobody else around. Not even a guard.

"What the hell? Why did you bring us here? I thought we were going to the girls in Axis Mundi!" Pausing, I wave my hand to indicate the empty room. "And where is everyone?!"

Alpha grunts. "You interrupted me. I was trying to focus my mind, and you kept asking dumb questions. I couldn't focus on Cassiel, so I brought us here. Jeez, just gimme a second."

A second passes. Then two. Three.

Harold frowns and taps his smartwatch. "Son... this date..."

Alpha glowers at the old man. "Shush. I found her. Cassiel and Samantha are about two hundred miles away, as the crow flies. Cassiel seems distressed, like she's fighting or something."

"Fighting?! Two hundred miles?! Where did you take us?"

Harold holds up his watch to show me its display, but the string of numbers means nothing to me. "We missed the return doohickey. It's been 'bout two months 'n sixteen days since we left."

Two and a half months?! My mind blares several alarms at once. " **Locate!** " Instantly, my mind finds Cassiel, partially thanks to Alpha giving me a ballpark estimate of her location. " **Teleport!** "

Leaving the other three behind, I catch Alpha's mouth open as he starts to yell '*stop!*' However, it's too late. I'm already gone.

A moment later the deafening sound of an explosion makes my ears ring. I'm knocked backward as a grenade erupts, sending shrapnel all over and hitting every chunk of my body.

"Ah!" I let out a weak yelp and go flying back, hitting something unthinkably hard, and probably metal.

After a moment, my ears stop ringing. I blink and gather my wits, start pulling out chunks of metal from my body, then yell, " **Heal!** "

War. A battle of epic proportions is taking place in front of me. I quickly scan the horizon. I'm inside the labyrinth, but it's barely recognizable. Massive chunks have been blown out of the walls, and enormous sections of labyrinth walls litter the landscape, raising into the air like tiny office buildings. The ground is uneven, descending into dips and valleys, and the room looks like it's been deliberately carved out to form as much open space as possible.

My blood cools as I realize the awful hissing noises are from Kolvaxians. " **Storage.** " Within three seconds, I place the Crown of Solomon on my head and pull up my mental map. This place is very close to the portal that leads to Volgarius Alpha, the world where I found Ionis. *Did the Kolvaxians already find it? Are the humans okay?*

God, I can't believe I'm thinking of them at a time like this. They've been turned by now. No way they escaped the Kolvaxians. More importantly, where is Cassiel? Samantha?

"Undulating Joy: Oh look, it is the biological that left this unit without a companion." A robotic voice behind me makes me jump to my feet, though I wince from the pain.

"OMEN?"

"Response: Correct. That is my designation. I see that your mental faculties have degraded by less than one-point-three percent."

A horrible scream of a man being tackled by monsters makes my stomach flinch. "I don't have time for this. Where is Cassiel? Where's Samantha?"

Turning to look in the direction of the arena-like area, I flinch as three men rush past me, guns raised, oblivious to my presence. They jump toward a Kolvaxian that appears from nowhere and blast it in the chest and brain, and the human-like monster hisses in agony before disappearing back into the ground.

One of the men holds his hand up to stop their charge, then taps something on his ear before rushing forward. Once again, a different Kolvaxian, female this time, jumps up and attacks them, but they manage to get the drop on her before she can hit them. She dips back into the ground, and I stare in awe all the while.

"They're fighting those monsters... and winning? How?!"

The ground vibrates underneath me suddenly, as if a micro-quake were occurring, and a moment later, it stops again.

"Thoughtful Response: Given your first question, the answer is that the biological designated Cassiel is currently on the frontlines inside the arena. This OMEN unit does not know her precise position. As for your second query, the biologicals are losing ground slowly to the Kolvaxians."

"They are?" I shoot him a questioning glance, but the robot stares blankly at me.

"Amusement: The biologicals are unable to combat the Kolvaxians fully. Soon all will be transformed into Class C biologicals, except for this OMEN unit. It will likely be disassembled and thrown in a landfill. Poetic."

I ignore his weird quirkiness. "But they were fighting those Kolvaxians just now! And winning!"

A hand grabs my shoulder and a deep voice barks in my ear. "What the fuck are you doing standing around, dipshit?! Grab a gun and help us fight, you little pansy-ass piece of-" The voice cuts off suddenly. "Jason?"

I turn to see who's talking. It's Benjamin Brown. He stares at me in shock. "It's World War goddamn Seven out here, and you've been off smelling roses and scratching your ass! Where have you been?!"

"I was only gone for a day. Jason Alpha screwed up and returned us much later in the timestream. Are Cassiel and Samantha okay?"

He notices the urgency in my eyes. "Yeah, kid. They're fine, for now. The problem is, these goddamn scum-suckers are already inside the Labyrinth! We can barely keep them in this area by blasting sonic pulses in the ground, but they'll escape soon enough, and everything'll go to shit!"

Sonic pulses. That must have been the vibration I felt. "How long have you guys been fighting the Kolvaxians?"

"Two weeks." An explosion a hundred feet away makes Ben flinch, so he grabs my jacket and hauls me over behind a wall. The sound of plasma-fire in the distance is like a jackhammer pounding into a vat of jellybeans. "We fight nonstop! My boys barely get a few hours of sleep, and have to constantly reinforce each other! Don't even think about poor Tvoorik! That son of a bitch hasn't slept at all!"

"Tvoorik?"

Ben nods. "Yeah. Tvoorik's the only one who can sense the little bastards. He's using those earpieces of yours to coordinate our troops wherever the monsters show up."

More questions answered. Great. "Where's Cassiel? I'm going to go help her."

"The fuck you are." A voice just to my side makes me jerk up in surprise. Alpha's standing there, staring at me. "I'll take care of this. *This time*. Don't go rushing off just because you have a death wish."

I nod at him. "I won't. Sorry."

Alpha growls as he looks toward the battlefield. "Fucking hell. They've already made it here. I'm going to have to take drastic measures."

Drastic measures. I don't know if I like the sound of that.

Part 484c: Deus Ex Machina

"I'm going to have to take drastic measures," Alpha says. His eyes sweep around as he evaluates the battlefield. "Once Kolvaxians arrive in a place like the Labyrinth, they can't be stopped. If we're lucky, one nuclear blast should annihilate enough space that it will destroy the gate they're arriving from, and erase those caught within. I'll have to work fast, though."

I don't get to offer any protest because Ben grabs and shoves me aside. "You're going to go nuclear?! Not a chance! We've got this under control! I don't want you here!"

"I'm not asking for permission," Alpha says. "You should pull all your troops out. I'll give you ten minutes. That's all. Anyone caught in the blast will be as dead as if the monsters had turned them anyway. A quick death is a blessing in disguise."

"You can't do that." Ben lowers his voice and looks around warily. "I don't care if you *are* a wordsmith traveling through time. We've been fighting these bastards for two weeks now. Reinforcements are coming. We're about to start pushing back. If you use the nuclear option, we'll not only lose good men and women; you'll also undo all of our preparation."

"Preparation?" Alpha shoots a confused look at Ben. "There is no 'preparation.' The best minds across the multiverse have been fighting the Kolvaxians in the 10K universe for millions of years. They lose territory every single day. You don't stand a chance at beating them. Now that I'm here, we're doing this my way."

"You... you little... fucking..." Ben growls deep in his throat. "This ain't the 'Tenkay' universe. We thought you were gone forever, once the first two weeks passed without your return. Given that bleak reality, we poured our blood, sweat, and tears into formulating a defense against these parasites. I will *not* let you come in here, swing your dick around, and destroy our hard work."

Before Alpha can reply, I grab his arm. "Hold on. Alpha, didn't you say that you couldn't detect Kolvaxians once they were underground?"

He flashes a look of irritation at me. "Yeah. So?"

"We can. That is, *they* can. Ben and his team. Tvoorik can sense the Kolvaxians, and he's coordinating attacks on them whenever they pop up."

As if to emphasize my point, three Kolvaxians leap from the ground several dozen feet away and tackle a female commando. Before she can land on her back and get sucked under, six soldiers jump out from behind rocks and pepper the green-skinned monsters with the same

metal barbs we once used against the Grez. The powerful kick of the weapons knocks the soldiers slightly off their feet, but the damage to each of the three Kolvaxians is incredible. Their chests explode outwards as the bolts smash into their back, and one of the monsters' heads is blown half-off.

The two that manage to survive hiss at the soldiers, then clamber off the woman, and suck back into the terrain. To my surprise, the lines attached to the bolts go underground with them. With remarkable agility, two soldiers each grab hold of the lines, tie them together, and attach a small device. They then jump back, and the gadget sends a visible current of electricity through the cable, likely hitting the affected Kolvaxians attached to each wire.

Alpha narrows his eyes as he watches the scene. Suddenly, a flash of realization appears. "Tvoorik. Wait! You mean that one little demon? The Oracle variant?"

Ben nods, but continues to glare at Alpha. "Yeah! As I said, we've got the situation under control! He tracks them, then sends the information to our soldiers, and we coordinate our attacks. If you blow up the battlefield, he'll die!"

A strange smile appears on Alpha's face. "Incredible. I didn't- that is, nobody has ever been able to track Kolvaxians once they go underground. The anti-energy in their bodies confounds my locating abilities, and echolocation pumped into the ground is too slow to follow their movements." After a moment, his smile disappears. "Still, even if you can track them, you can't stop them. They'll fan out, slither past you, and enter the labyrinth, turning everyone they encounter into more Kolvaxians. The time to stop them was before they arrived, not after. You're just too late."

Cassiel's voice startles me, as she flies down and lands beside me. "I'm not losing faith. Jason, where have you been?" The first sentence is directed at Alpha, but the next at me. "After you jumped away and didn't return, Sam and I thought you had died!"

"From my point of view, we were only gone a few hours. *Alpha* screwed up and returned us to the wrong time. I'm sorry I frightened you." I quickly lean over and kiss her on the cheek, then pull away. "Alpha wants to nuke this whole place, killing all the Kolvaxians in the area."

"I know," Cass says, as she touches one of the telepathic earpieces. "Ben relayed the conversation to me. Samantha is due back any minute. With the help of the demons, we can return fire and push the monsters back."

Alpha grumbles audibly. "I'm telling you, even if Tvoorik can sense their position underground, you can't contain them! Every second we waste, they crawl further away. Once they're out of nuclear range, you lose, end of story."

Ben shakes his head. "No, you're wrong. They can't escape this quarantine zone, not yet. We're blasting the ground every ten minutes with high-frequency sound waves, disrupting their movement. Every time they pass a certain boundary, Tvoorik gives the signal, and we hit them again."

Alpha spends several seconds staring Ben down. Awe appears in his eyes. "You figured out a way to prevent their movement." It isn't a question.

"Yes," Cassiel interjects before Ben can reply. "And whatever you were thinking of doing, don't. You've done too much already."

"What do you mean by *that*?" Alpha turns to eyeball her suspiciously. "I saved your asses twice now."

"Once." Cass corrects him. "Against Satan. Thank you for that. However, you also destroyed the Volgrim homeworld, Melkin. Then you left, and took Jason with you, leaving us no way to travel to Voldarius. The extra Volgrim might just overload their planet's scant resources. I doubt they have enough to survive."

For once, a look of anger spreads over Cassiel's face. "More importantly, what you did was unforgivable. There were millions of Volgrim still alive on Melkin. You killed all of them. I don't like your tactics. I don't like *you*. At this point, you're as big of a threat to this galaxy as the Kolvaxians are."

Alpha takes a step back, visibly stunned at her proclamation. "What the hell? You can't be-" He's interrupted as the ground rumbles violently once more, likely due to the sonic pulses Ben mentioned. "You can't be serious!"

"I'm dead goddamn serious." Cassiel takes a menacing step toward him and stabs a finger toward his face. "You told us how the Kolvaxians got here. You're the one who opened up the wormhole, so it's your fault they're here in the first place! Not only that, but you opened the wormhole when you destroyed the Volgrim homeworld the first time! How many times are you going to destroy their homeworlds?! Three? Ten?!"

Her words remind me of what Alpha told me in private. *He destroyed an entire universe once*. Come to think of it; he's killed more sentient beings than anyone here, including the Kolvaxians.

Who's the true monster?

The other me grumbles and looks away. "Fine, fine. Cripes. If you can't handle things, don't come begging me for help. I need to take Sparky and get out of here, anyway. We've got a mission to take care of, and-"

"I'm not going anywhere. Not yet." I interrupt him before he can finish his sentence, which visibly pisses him off, but I don't care. Cassiel's opinion holds more weight than this self-proclaimed champion of justice, and I'm interested in learning how she figured out how to combat them. "You just stay back. I'll help Cass out, and together, we'll save our universe."

Cassiel taps her finger to her ear and looks away for a moment. "Sam's back. She's back!" As if the rest of us aren't here, Cassiel ignores our presence, jumps into the air, and flies away, likely to meet up with Samantha.

Ben sighs, and relief washes over his face. "Thank the gods. Jason, you want to help, right?"

I nod quickly, realizing he isn't talking to Alpha. "Yeah. What's up?"

"I need you to use your brain. You can create objects and machines out of thin air, right?"

"Yeah."

"Great. You'll make the next step much easier."

* * *

"Oh my god! Jason!" Samantha squeaks excitedly and jumps into my arms, nearly knocking me over. "We missed you! Where have you been?!"

Her delight at seeing me feels out of place, given the carnage taking place just around the corner. Cassiel, Alpha, and Ben watch from a few feet away as we stay outside the Containment Zone, where the sonic pulses prevent the Kolvaxians from escaping.

"Time travel stuff. It's boring, really," I say, as I shoot a glance at Alpha. Sam pulls away from me, and her smile is much more radiant than I last remember. Usually, it's Cassiel who smiles innocently, while Samantha always looks like she's thinking something lewd, but their roles seem reversed, at least for the moment. "So these are the reinforcements you brought?"

I gesture to the group of several hundred demons waiting patiently on the sidelines. Each of them has an air of nobility, as if they're more than just grunts meant to meatshield in battle. Confirming my suspicions, Sam nods. "Yes, these demons are brave Lords, all of whom wish to help protect their home. I couldn't find any Dukes in time, but Lords are quite powerful too."

Alpha is unconvinced. "What will a few hundred demons accomplish? You're fighting a nearly unending horde that will keep pouring through the portal. No matter how you struggle, they will still win. The best you can hope for is pushing them back out of the Labyrinth. They've-

"

"Shut up already," Ben grunts. "We told you to stay out of our business. There is a plan, and you're not part of it."

"Fine, fine." Alpha throws his hands in the air and starts to stomp away. "Sorry I asked."

He continues to walk, and soon he's well out of earshot. *Though, my mind whispers, he could always pretend that's the case, but enhance his hearing with thoughtsmithing, and we wouldn't even know. Hell, he could read all of our minds too.*

It's probably better I don't think about it.

Once Alpha's gone, Ben grins at the giant crate full of items I've synthesized. "You made our job a lot easier."

Samantha, who wasn't here when I made them a few minutes ago, stares at the items curiously. "What are those? The barbs look nasty."

I glance over at the circular objects. They're small enough to fit in the palm of someone's hands, and the underside has a row of metal spikes shaped similarly to porcupine quills lining the edges, with a thicker, longer lance in the middle. It's about the length of a horseshoe stake, and is sharp enough to etch metal.

Ben's grin widens. "These bad boys are how we'll take the fuckers down. They're multipurpose tracking devices. If our frontliners can slap these on a Kolvaxian, then we can track them anywhere, allowing Tvoorik to rest for a while once the time is right. They're explosive, and they can deliver an agonizing pulse of electricity right to the monster's spine. They pack a punch."

I nod. "They're nearly impossible to pull out, thanks to the reversed barbs on each spike. Not only that but if a Kolvaxian tries to remove the device, it self-destructs."

Samantha slaps her fist into her palm. "Oh! So if we attach these to every Kolvaxian, they aren't even a threat anymore!"

"In theory," Ben replies, caution in his voice. "The 'Spine Mines,' as I call them, won't prevent a Kolvaxian from attacking someone, but we should be able to detonate the device and kill them anytime we want."

"Really?" Alpha appears again from nowhere, making me sigh. "But don't you have to get in melee range to use them?"

Ben scowls. "Didn't you leave? Never mind, don't answer that. Yeah, we have to get up close and personal to slap the Spine Mines on, but that's why we have Tvoorik."

Alpha nods. "I'm beginning to get the picture. To be honest, in the 10K universe, Oracles are mostly extinct, along with the rest of demonkind. The Kolvaxians hit their Labyrinth first. We didn't have a way to track them initially, but if we had, it could have perhaps made a small difference."

Ben glances at me, then back to Alpha. "If that's your idea of a compliment, thanks. The problem is, it ain't all Oracles who can sense where Kolvaxians are. Only Tvoorik can. Probably because he's a Unique Variant."

Samantha reaches into the crate and pulls out one of the Spine Mines. "Jason, love, you should make more of these. A whole bunch more, even. I'm going to join in on the fun."

I nod. "Sure thing."

Alpha raises an eyebrow. "Even if you *can* locate their positions and you have this 'foolproof' plan, I don't see how you can be so nonchalant."

Samantha smiles brightly at him, like the midday sun. "I'm not! I'm just looking forward to tearing them apart, especially after what they did to Cass a couple of days ago."

It occurs to me that there might be a hint of madness in her eyes. Alpha and I left for nearly three months... I wonder what happened during that time.

Cass rubs her shoulder. "It was barely a scratch. You don't need to work yourself up on my account."

Samantha ignores her and grabs a second Spine Mine. "Jason, could you be a dear and make some more of those telepathic earpieces for the Demon Lords? I'm going on ahead by myself for the moment."

"Sure thing, Sam," I say, feeling momentary *deja vu*.

She motions to several of the Demon Lords, and they nod at Cassiel, barely acknowledge the rest of us, and form a line to grab two Spine Mines each.

While they do that, I aim my mind at Cassiel's earring. " **Copy. Copy. Copy.** " Each time I copy, I add the copies together, creating two, then four, then eight...

Within fifteen copies a goddamn mountain of earpieces lies in a heap, separating Cassiel from me. Stacking up to chest level, they clog the hallway a little bit. Each of the demon lords looks at me, reluctantly takes one of the earrings, then continues after Samantha, though many of them have to jump the pile to keep moving.

Cassiel clears her throat. "I think that's enough, Jason."

"Yeah. I figured as much."

Not wanting to dilly-dally, I continue copying the Spine Mines, though due to their size and complexity, I can't copy them en-masse as I did with the earpieces, but I make do, churning out more and more of them as the minutes pass.

Alpha wanders away to observe the battle, leaving Cassiel, Ben, and I alone. Cass twiddles her fingers together as I pause to take a break from the copying. "I'm glad you came back. To be honest, I didn't think, even with our planning, that we could beat the Kolvaxians without your help."

Oof. Here it comes. "I'm not here for good. Alpha wants to keep an eye on me. He thinks I'm Hope."

"Hope?" Ben frowns. "I mean, I guess, in a way, you're the hope of humanity, but--"

"He doesn't mean like that," Cassiel says, correcting his line of thinking. "You didn't live in the Labyrinth, so I guess you wouldn't know, but at one point Jason created a few hundred clones. One of them turned rogue somehow, took me hostage, and then Jason unlocked his new powers as the 'god-king' and saved me. However, a catastrophic battle nearly ruined Hero City. Jason barely eked out a win against his copy."

Ben scrunches up his face. "What's that have to do with hope?"

"Hope was the name of the clone who turned evil," Cass replies.

"Really? Sounds like a stripper name." Ben shrugs and looks toward the battle. "I'll be back. I need to see how things are going."

Cass nods. "Okay."

Ben walks away, leaving Cass and me together. I glance down at the pile of Spine Mines. "We should go. They need us on the battlefield."

Cassiel pokes at the pile of earpieces separating us. "Are you leaving after this?"

I knew this was coming. "Yeah. Well, eventually. Alpha insists I go with him." Seeing a look of sadness in her eyes, I quickly continue. "Ahh, however, he did say that time travel is different from how you might imagine. We could spend a hundred years in another universe, come back to this one, and only a day will pass." I pause, remembering what just happened. "Then again, he's terrible at going to the right time."

"Yeah..." Cass trails off and glances back at the war unfolding. "Can't you just tell him no? If he can come back in a day, he doesn't need you at all. He could leave you here, do whatever, and come back a day later. You wouldn't go anywhere."

Huh. Now that she mentions it, Alpha doesn't need me after all. Helen *did* say that traveling to the future isn't the same as jumping to the past. What did she mean by that?

"I can ask him, but don't expect-" I get cut off as a horrible, blood-curdling scream rings out. Jerking my eyes from Cassiel to the battlefield, I just barely catch a female commando flying into the air, then smashing into the ground with a sickening *crunch*.

"What was that?" Cassiel turns around to look, but a fire must be breaking out, because smoke starts to fill the room. "Let's put a hold on this discussion. Come with me, and we'll see what's going on."

"Yeah, sounds good." Not wanting to take several seconds getting over there, I wordsmith. "**Teleport.**"

Cassiel pops over with me and stumbles slightly, not expecting the sudden change in scenery. Despite this, she collects herself and doesn't bother frowning. She's too distracted by the uproar from our troops.

As I thought, smoke is beginning to spread, but it's coming from the far end of the room, the one where the portal to Volgarius is.

"They got the Lieutenant! Fall back!" A man yells from the smoke. Just as he emerges, something grabs his leg and hoists him into the air, but I can't see what it is.

Cassiel's face whitens. "It's- it's the same as when they grabbed me."

The telekinesis attack! I jump forward, using my superior God-King agility, and grab the man before the Kolvaxians raise him higher. I still can't see any of them through the smoke. "Hang on! I've got you!"

As the words leave my mouth, I suddenly accelerate upward as the invisible tendrils grab my leg and try to pull me apart from the soldier, then he gets lifted too, but still, I hold on.

" **Invincible!** " I yell the word out after aiming my mind at both our bodies a split second before the invisible force hurls us down with tremendous force. This time I lose my grip, and we get pulverized into the rocks and dirt at the same time, though we don't take damage.

"Get it off! Lemme go!" The man swings futilely at whatever's grabbing his leg before suddenly yelping in surprise as it releases him. I pull myself up, sighing as the invisible 'hands' let me go too.

The smoke continues to thicken, but a few brave souls jump in, grab the soldier and I, and pull us out. The woman leading me along chatters nervously. "We're falling back, God-King. The Kolvaxians are creating this smoke artificially, it inhibits mental functions and induces disorientation and nausea."

"Seriously?" As we arrive at the smoke's boundary, I wave my hand to clear it away from my face. "How did you figure that out so fast?"

She points at Alpha, standing nearby. "He told us. One of your clones?"

The look of unease on her face, given everyone's memories of the Clone Wars, is justified. "Twin brother."

After she runs off to help some other soldiers, I jump to Alpha's side. "You know about this smoke?"

"Of course. What part of 'the Kolvaxians can overwhelm battle-hardened wordsmiths and armies' didn't you understand? You've barely begun to see their abilities. Every species they assimilate gives them new powers, and mixing their abilities up will only lead to deadlier results."

I nod and take a quick mental tally. *Entering and exiting the ground, telekinesis that assumes the form of hands, disorienting smoke, and many other abilities we haven't seen yet. This war is only just beginning.*

"Get down!" Ben jumps from the smoke and plows forward, knocking me to the ground. At that instant, a blob of green mucus flies through the air, sails over his body, and *splats* on the ground. A hissing sound follows as the dirt and stone dissolve partially, before the green color shifts and turns brown.

Ben jumps up and pulls me to my feet. Alpha coughs. "Oh, right. They also have acid spit."

"Are you kidding?! That nearly killed me!" My hand clenches into a fist as every muscle in my body screams at me to punch the son of a bitch. "You wanna tell us right now if they have any other tricks we should watch out for?!"

"Nah." He looks away casually. "You've got this under control, remember? Chop Chop! Don't let more people die. The only reason I'll intervene is if the Kolvaxians grab you. I can't let a Wordsmith fall into their hands, after all."

I want to punch him so badly. "Thanks," I say, biting the word off.

* * *

Minutes pass. After reforming a wall of troops, composed of humans and the Demon Lords, I listen to my earpiece and follow Tvoorik's commands. If he realizes I'm listening, he doesn't show it.

Private Horace, Private Marisa, and Lieutenant Dan are the next targets! Ready the ambush! Tvoorik's voice appears in everyone's mind, compelling them to action.

The three people who he mentions step away from the group, and as expected, the invisible hands grab them and start hauling them into the smoke, but I'm ready this time. " **PULL!** "

My wordsmithing not only yanks the soldiers toward me but three Kolvaxians as well. The buggers stumble out of the smoke, blank expressions on their faces, as every demon forms hand signs and every human blasts the Kolvaxians with a hail of gunfire.

Unexpectedly, the plasma ricochets off the Kolvaxian's bodies in all directions, as if they're wearing invisible armor. From the sides of the smoke, ten Kolvaxians leap out aim their hands at us, and bolts of lightning shoot forward, scattering the men and women as deafening *booms* explode from the ground wherever their lightning hits.

"What the fuck?! How did they-?!" I yell words, only to realize my ears are bleeding. I can't hear what I'm saying! " **Heal!** "

A stunning light blasts out from the fog, blinding me right as I get my hearing back! My brain screams in pain, and the sensation of falling washes over me, but I can only flail around as I flop back.

My head smashes into the dirt, and it takes me a moment to realize why I can't move properly. My body is still invincible, so my sense of touch is completely gone, in addition to my sight. The sound of hundreds of Kolvaxians hissing, and the screams of men and women as the monsters leap from the smoke at them ring in my ears.

Watch out! Their attack pattern has changed! There's- there's too much activity! I can't track all of them at once! Tvoorik's mental voice appears again, and his tone is panicked. *They're switching their strategy to all-out assault! Their goal is to break the Sonic Disruption Generators so they can burrow underground and escape the containment zone. Protect the generators with your lives!*

Terror floods over me. This isn't like before. Were the Kolvaxians just testing us? They only attacked three or four at a time, but now...

" **Heal!** " My eyesight returns just as a Kolvaxian jumps at me. Planting my feet into the ground, I shove my body back, scooting across the ground like a human skateboard, and lunging my right foot up with all the strength I can muster, as I deliver a skull-busting blow right to the Kolvaxian's kisser. The monstrosity blasts into the air and smashes against the ceiling, as if I were Superman, and not just myself, splattering its body all over the goddamn place.

Jumping to my feet, I gasp. The tables have turned. This new strategy is reaping crazy rewards for the Kolvaxians, and it takes me a moment to realize what this means. *They're learning, and studying our tactics. They aren't mindless; it's just a pretense.*

A nearby Demon Lord screams in agony as a Kolvaxian bites her shoulder with its razor sharp teeth, sinking its fangs into her. Before it can get any further, I dash over and pound the motherfucker with my invincible boot, knocking its head off like a bowling ball and sending the rest of its body sprawling back. Already, the woman's skin is starting to turn green. " **Disintegrate. Void. Restructure. Rebuild. Heal.** "

Using the same words I used on Benjamin Brown when I first met him, I systematically use the Crown of Solomon to pinpoint the cells in the demoness's body and teleport them out, to another dimension, before repairing the damage to her body. "Get up! Use all your power, and crush the enemy!"

She nods breathlessly at me and scrambles to her feet. "R-right! I'm on it!"

I saved one woman, but the Kolvaxians are still emerging. At this rate, they'll overwhelm us. Shit, no wonder Alpha said that getting in melee range would be a problem. Spine Mines only work on a few Kolvaxians at once. Against a swarm like this, they're useless!

From behind me, a sensation of heat forms. I quickly turn back to see a colossal, perfectly spherical ball of fire suspended in the air. Underneath it is a face I didn't expect to see here, let alone *ever*.

"Seven Devils. You're making a mess of *my* Labyrinth," Says the figure. "I'm here to help clean up, and I brought a few friends."

"Beelzebub?"

I stare in shock as he hurls the colossal orb of fire past our troops and the battle on the frontlines, and it sails forward at an incredible speed, then detonates with hell and fury in the distance, beyond the wall of smoke. A wave of heat, hot enough to make my invincible body sweat, blasts out and clears the smoke from the area.

"Bael. You help our troops. I'll take out the trash." Beelzebub holds his fingers up, and five tiny balls of fire appear above each one, just like the flames he used against me. His eyes rapidly scan the now-visible and very confused Kolvaxians as they pause to evaluate the newest threat. "Get out of my way, Wordsmith. It'd be a darn shame if one of these hit you by accident."

I don't know if he's my ally, but the enemy of my enemy is my friend, as the old proverb says. I quickly jump in the air just before he hurls the fireballs, narrowly avoiding what might have been a fiery death. Then again, I *am* invincible, so perhaps not.

The pinpricks of flame slam into five Kolvaxians, detonate, and a circle of fire expands outward, engulfs them, and turns their bodies to ash in an instant. Bael takes the opportunity to leap into the fray, and starts yanking Kolvaxians off of screaming demons and humans alive, tearing them apart with his bare hands. "Stupid! Weak! Puny!"

I turn to Beelzebub. "You're helping us! Why?"

Beelzebub scowls at me. "I'm only doing what's in my best interests. Don't confuse it with an alliance. You idiots didn't even think to destroy the portal they're emerging from. What would you do without me?" He sighs and holds up both hands, as ten more fireballs appear.

"Humans. This is why they will always be inferior."

Part 485c: One Little Mouse

Ten pinpricks of fire lunge from the tips of Beelzebub's fingers, like minuscule fairies on a quest to devour life. A few Kolvaxians dive for the ground but are too slow, and shriek in agony as the flames explode into flesh-devouring globes that engulf their bodies. Beelzebub activates ten more, without even using the hand signs that demons usually do when performing magic. "Devil's sake. This is going to take a while."

Three Kolvaxians lunge toward Bael and dig their claws and incisors into his back, hissing all the while. Bael doesn't even wince, instead opting to jerk both hands back, tear two of them off, and crush them into pulp in his grasp. The last Kolvaxian, seeing what happened to its comrades, thinks better of its life's decisions and leaps away. It dives underground to safety, where Bael can't reach it.

"Coward," Bael mutters, before backhanding a different monster attacking from his blind spot. The poor thing explodes the instant his hand makes contact, demonstrating his incredible strength. I almost snicker at the sight of one of the two Kolvaxian's arms still embedded in his back. He must have torn the monster off, but its limb got left behind in the process.

Cassiel flies up and points her index finger at a Kolvaxian. A thin beam of light shoots out, like a laser made of holy energy, and hits an invisible barrier on the monster's head. *Anti-energy*.

I glance at Beelzebub, who stares at the Kolvaxians with a clinical disinterest, and summons more fireballs to lob at them. He doesn't smile, frown, or display any emotion as he exterminates ten more of the green-skinned threats. "What are you looking at, Wordsmith?"

Despite the blank expression on his face, his voice boils with hostility. I ignore it. "Cassiel's attacks do not affect the Kolvaxians since they imbued their bodies with anti-energy, yet your fireballs do. Why?"

Beelzebub rolls his eyes. "I ignite the fire with magic, but the resultant reaction is entirely natural once the flames leave my control. The winged one must sustain her attack via magical energy since Holy Magic is entirely artificial. It exists outside the confines of what humans would call 'scientific limitations.' Any other questions?"

His answer is very wordy, especially given he's a demon. He should know little of science, given what Samantha has told me about demons. "How do you-"

He cuts me off. "I comprehend the power of flames. I respect them. I learn from them. Fire is my sole weapon, and so I must know both its limitations, as well as its advantages."

A lot of good that did you against Jason Alpha, I think to myself.

I watch in silence as he continues to mop up the Kolvaxians at an alarming rate. At one point, they pull back and all dive underground to escape his flames, which finally provokes agitation from Beelzebub. His lip curls up and a snarl forms. "Accursed fiends. They come into *my* Labyrinth, and haven't the guts to face me on equal terms? I'll put their heads on pikes. Bael! Smash the ground! Smash it to bits!"

Bael, over a hundred feet away, perks up. "Huh? What didja say?"

"You heard me!"

The big, lumbering Demon Duke nods slowly, and a smile forms on his face. "How hard?"

"If I'm still standing once you're finished, I'll never let you live it down!"

The smile on Bael's face turns maniacal. "I get to let loose, huh?"

Beelzebub widens his stance and shoots a glance at me. "Don't try this at home."

Bael roars, and suddenly his body inflates slightly, and his muscles bulge, as though just by willing his body, he can increase his strength dramatically. A moment later, he balls up his fists and screams angrily as he jumps into the air, touches the ceiling a hundred feet above, and pushes off with enough force to send a shockwave around the room.

Then he hits the ground.

Disorientation jostles me, as my legs buckle and I get flung up and spin head over heels through the air. The instant I hit the ground, I get sent flying again, and through my spinning, I can just barely make out the figures of other humans and demons alike sharing similar fates. My perpetual pinwheeling comes to a halt as something grabs me by the waist and raises me in the air. It only takes a second for me to shake the swimming feeling from my mind before I realize It's Cass who saved me.

She doesn't smile. "Make yourself wings again!"

"Right. **Wings.**" She releases me as I catch myself and fly alongside her. Only once I get a look at what's going on do I see the carnage Bael is causing. He bounces like a goddamn ping-pong ball, smashing from ceiling to ground over and over again, sending out ripples of rock and stone as the ground and sky scream to escape his brutish body. However, while it does force Kolvaxians to leap out of the ground, lest they have their organs melted from the shockwaves his impacts deliver, it also sends demons and humans careening around uncontrollably.

A double-edged blade.

I see what you're going for, Beelzebub, my mind whispers, but you're going to kill us along with them!

Beelzebub, for his part, levitates in the air, releasing fire from the soles of his boots to stay aloft. Every time a Kolvaxian leaps from the ground, he shoots a fireball at them, incinerating their body before they can even hiss in pain.

I can't let him continue like this. A commando sails past me, unable to even let out a whimper of pain as the air has been ejected from his body. Before he hits the ground, I speak a word.

" **Slow!** "

Time screeches almost to a halt. I now have precious moments to formulate a plan. First order of business: stop Bael's rampaging.

" **Envelop.** " One word later, and a thick layer of hardened foam surrounds his body. Enough, the Crown tells me, to absorb the next few impacts he'll make.

A glance to my side reveals Ben Brown, dashing toward Beelzebub, fist raised. Given what happened the last time he punched Beelzy, the First Emperor is probably about to die. " **Teleport.** " I send him five feet to his left, so that if his momentum keeps up, he'll just barely miss his target.

Several humans are probably about to die if they don't get any medical treatment, especially the ones currently hurtling to the ground. " **Return. Heal.** " All of our human troops are sent back to the outpost just outside Hero City, and their wounds are healed. They aren't necessary anymore.

We need to capture some of the Kolvaxians. If Beelzebub keeps his attack up, they'll all be killed. I aim my mind at the crate of Spine Mines. " **Control.** " Dozens of the mines leap from the boxes, aim their spikes forward, and lunge at the Kolvaxians I can see. Only now do I notice that the Kolvaxians are able to move somewhat compared to the other humans and demons in the room. *Is it because their bodies are coated in anti-energy?* No matter. At the least, they're much slower than they were before.

Three Spine Mines stab into each Kolvaxian I can see, and their mouths open to wheeze painfully. I'm certain I just broke several of their bones but-

Ugh. Slowing time drains a ton of my energy. I'm starting to feel woozy. Better wrap this up quickly.

Beelzebub's fireballs are a problem. I just tagged the Kolvaxians, so if he kills them, then it will have been for naught. We need live specimens to experiment on. " **Extinguish.** "

His fireballs snuff from existence. Now all that's left are a whole bunch of demons, Cassiel, Ben Brown, myself, and-

"Yo." Alpha appears in front of me. "Quick thinking."

Usually, he'd startle me, but that doesn't happen this time. My breathing is already irregular. My heart is pumping almost twice as fast as it usually does. The strain on my body from slowing time is enormous. "Thanks. I'm going t-to resume time now."

Before he replies, the pain in my chest vanishes. "No need. I'll keep it slowed for you. Well, you only dropped it down to 25%, but I reduced it to 1%. Might as well be stopped at this point."

Like an anvil no longer hangs from my neck, my breathing returns to normal. "Ah, oh. Thanks, I guess. What do you want this time?"

I'm a little irritated that he's taking over once again, but his posture is relaxed. He isn't as angry as he was several minutes ago. "I just wanted to say... I was wrong."

"Huh? Wrong?"

"Yeah." Alpha lowers his head. "You don't need me here, after all. I can't believe it myself. Maybe because of luck, or some other circumstance, this universe can resist the Kolvaxian threat after all. At least, it can for now. Maybe I'm jaded. I thought resisting them was a pointless endeavor."

"I see." Two words are all I can manage for a few moments. "You've changed your mind. Why?"

Alpha shrugs. "Once I calmed down and stopped trying to assert my will, I realized that if push came to shove, I could just collapse this universe. I've considered doing the same thing to 10K, but didn't, since the Marie Council is only worried the Kolvaxians will learn of the Central Hub. Anything less than that is a 'local matter,' so Marie would prefer to leave 10K intact."

Alpha glances away from me, toward Samantha, who's about to land spryly on her hands and feet like a cat. The jostling from Bael isn't enough to knock her off-balance, it seems. "I don't want to destroy this universe. It's just one stream out of many others, but it's my origin point. I came from this universe. If it can be saved, my heart will be more at ease."

Despite his positive wording, the part where he considered destroying the universe leaves a sour taste in my mouth. He may think of himself as a champion of justice, but Cassiel is right to distrust him.

"We'll do what we can, then. If you don't mind, though, maybe we can have this conversation later? There's still a battle raging." I glance to my side where Cassiel's frozen in midair.

Alpha blinks in surprise. "Oh, right! I almost forgot."

"Did you really?"

"Nope." Alpha shrugs, vanishes, and an instant later, time returns to normal. Cassiel starts to move and catch the commando who was falling, only to stop and stare in confusion at the blank space where he once was.

Beelzebub falters, as he realizes his flames are gone. After a moment, more ignite over his fingertips, but he turns his head back to scowl at me. "Stay out of this, Wordsmith. I'm dealing with the monsters!"

Cassiel jumps in before I can reply. "Stop attacking, Beelzebub. We've won, and we need captive Kolvaxians."

The fireballs suspended above his fingers grow slightly bigger as he whips his head to her. "I disagree! These monsters need to be wiped out! Your mercy will only allow them to spread their toxins further!"

Ben Brown careens past Beelzebub and plows into a wall, but his Hypersuit absorbs the damage. He jumps back and looks around in confusion. "What the hell? I was about to knock that smug son of a bitch off his rocker!"

The Kolvaxians jump back underground, and Bael's body hits the ground with far less force, as the sphere of 'foam' surrounding him absorbs the impact. He scrambles to his feet and starts wiping it off angrily, but now his rage from before is noticeably less since confusion has replaced it.

Tvoorik's voice transmits to my mind from my earpiece. *Sixty-five Kolvaxians left.*

All these things happen at once, making it hard for me to focus, but I do my best and sort things by their priority level. "Beelzebub, stop with the flames. You've helped us enough. We need to take out the remaining Kolvaxians with surgical precision, and if Bael keeps causing a ruckus, he might destroy the sonic generators outside, freeing the Kolvaxians from this area. You don't want that."

Beelzebub pauses, and the fireballs above his hands falter. "Sonic generators?"

He doesn't know what they are. Fantastic. Ben looks like he's about to lay into the First Emperor, but I hold my hand up. "Stop."

A minute passes, and I quickly explain to Beelzebub our system. He nods along and lowers his hands. "So you plan to capture a few of the Kolvaxians and experiment on them to find their weaknesses? They seem plenty weak to me."

"They aren't," Ben says, correcting him. "We're only seeing a small number of them at once. Jason, your idea probably won't work. Kolvaxians can't be captured."

"They can't?"

"No. Their bodies can self-destruct. Beatrix once managed to capture two of them in the heat of a battle. As soon as we restrained them, our captives melted into green ooze, then dried up and turned to sand. It was disgusting." He flicks his eyes to the battle-scarred warzone, where craters and debris are scattered here and there. Bael continues to wrestle with the foam covering his body, but it sticks to him like ultra-hard concrete, as I designed it to do. Ben snorts inaudibly. "Look over there. The corpses of some of the monsters are already melting."

I follow his gaze, and indeed, they are.

Beelzebub licks his lips. "So, you mean to say that capturing them is impossible."

"Yes," Ben says, though he glowers at Beelzebub. "That doesn't mean I'll let you come in here and send my men and women flying around just so you can play the part of a hero. We had everything under control."

"Under control?" Beelzebub smirks. "I recall the moment I arrived, not fifteen minutes ago, and you were on your back as the swarm attacked. Try not to prostrate yourself thanking me. I saved your worthless life, after all."

Samantha jogs over, confusion on her face. "What's going on? Why have you stopped attacking?"

I turn to survey the battlefield again. Only a few Kolvaxians have emerged from the ground, but they hide behind chunks of debris and eye us warily. Once again, a thought returns to me. *They aren't mindlessly attacking. They keep stopping to evaluate our actions so they can learn about us.*

Indeed, the monsters standing in the open are the ones I tagged with the Spine Mines, though they don't appear to be in any pain. Hell, they aren't even short of breath, despite multiple circular explosives stabbed through various points on their bodies. The others are likely hiding underground, biding their time as they formulate a plan to counter attack, or they may be trying to escape.

I look at Sam. She's slightly winded but otherwise fine. "We're pausing to reconsider our strategy. So are the Kolvaxians, I think."

As if they want to make me look like an idiot, a dozen of the Kolvaxians standing around suddenly bolt forward and dash straight at Beelzebub. He jerks in surprise as they make their moves, but keeps his cool. "Sally forth and die, then!"

A medium sized ball of fire appears in the palm of his hand, but the monsters spread apart and jump in the air, aiming right for him. To my amazement, they each yank out a Spine Mine

from their bodies without flinching, despite a gruesome amount of flesh coming along for the ride. As they do, the mines activate their self-destruct mechanisms.

"Beelzebub! Look out!" I realize in an instant what's going to happen, but I don't have time to react.

Beelzebub falters, unable to launch his fireball at them. If he does, it will take him out along with the rest of us.

A flash of movement. Cassiel swoops in at the speed of sound and activates her Holy Barrier right as the mines explode. Like droplets of rain impacting the window of a car, the Kolvaxians detonate in a shower of gore as the explosions are reflected at the ceiling. Much of the kinetic energy from the blasts are lost, and seconds later, everyone breathes a sigh of relief.

She saved us all.

Beelzebub stutters and stammers for a moment, as he fumbles to find words. "You-! They almost... they moved so fast and-!"

Cassiel exhales and lowers her shield. "Fifty-three parasites left. You saved us; I saved you. That makes us even, doesn't it?"

Beelzebub's face pales. He steps away from her, and the flame in his hand dissipates. "You did no such thing! I was about to take them all out!"

Samantha strolls over to Beelzebub and rolls her eyes. "You know, it's okay to be wrong sometimes. You should thank Cassiel for saving your life. If you don't, you'll look like an ingrate."

This calms him down. Beelzebub's expression flattens as he gazes warily at the Demon Lords staring at him silently. Perhaps it's their eyes that put him over the edge, because he sighs audibly. "Haaah. Fine, fine. You have my gratitude."

"And you have mine," Cassiel echoes. "You did save us in our moment of need, after all."

"Mmm." Beelzebub grunts and turns his attention back to the battlefield. "There are still fifty-three left, as you said. What do *you* think we should do, pretty little angel?"

Cass glares at him. "Stop calling Jason 'Wordsmith,' and don't call me 'angel.' You know our names."

Beelzebub's expression turns smug. He's pleased by her irritation. "I'm sorry, Cassiel. What's your plan?"

Surprisingly, Cassiel turns to Ben. "You said we couldn't capture them, right?"

"Unfortunately not."

Bael finally tears the last bits of foam from his body and growls fiercely. "Hey! What the hell's all this white shit?!"

Cassiel ignores him and taps her lips. "Pull everyone back. Beelzebub, keep launching fireballs at any Kolvaxians who pop up. Instead of that big guy over there, we'll have Jason cause a localized earthquake; something that won't destroy the sonic generators or kill our people." She pauses, noticing the humans are all gone, except for Ben. Her body goes rigid. "Oh my god! Where is everyone?!"

"I healed and teleported them out. Don't worry." I quickly assuage her fears, and Cass breathes a sigh of relief.

"Okay, great. Well, the Spine Mines are a no-go. They just tear the bombs out and turn into kamikazes. If we can't capture them and we can't tag them, then we'll have to use the final option. Everyone pull back. Jason, Beelzebub, work together. I believe in both of you."

Beelzebub isn't keen on taking orders, especially given his position as First Emperor, but he sighs, knowing he's outmatched and outvoted. "Fine. Everyone pull back! You heard the woman! That means you too, Bael!"

The giant demon glances around, looking for a Kolvaxian to tear apart, but when none present themselves, he shrugs. "Fine. Damn skugs weren't giving me much of a fight anyway."

He lumbers toward us, and I aim my mind at the ground after he and everyone else are clear. "Are you ready, Beelzy?"

The First Emperor's eye twitches. "I'll seriously kill you if you keep calling me that."

"And I'll take that as a yes. **Earthquake!** "

The ground just beneath our feet makes no motion, but everywhere else in the giant, hollowed out room, a terrible rumbling and grinding begins, and cracks form as rock presses against rock, writhing and squirming like a maddened bull trying to buck its rider. Almost immediately, Kolvaxians begin leaping from the ground, but since there aren't any humans or demons in the way, Beelzebub uses a new tactic.

He hunches over, widens his legs, presses one hand to the ground, and forms a circle with his free hand, then presses it to his lips. What happens next makes me do a double-take. Beelzebub breathes fire, the heat of which instantly raises the temperature of the room dramatically, even where I'm standing, and a wave of flame screams out from his mouth, widening into a terrifying all-consuming cone. Just from the blinding whiteness of the blaze, I have to assume it's at least a thousand degrees, though I can only wince and look away as more Kolvaxians jump out of the frying pan and into the, err, fire.

He continues to breathe fire for a solid minute, and finally, the heat is too much for me to bear. I pull my mind away from the earthquake and wordsmith again, though speaking is agony with all the oxygen vanishing at lightning speed. **Resistant.** "The sweltering heat immediately loses its power over me, and even feels quite soothing. For a moment, I wonder if that's how Beelzebub is managing to survive the heat. Maybe he's immune to fire. If that's the case, then did he hold back his attack when the Kolvaxians jumped at him earlier, not out of worry for himself, but for us?

Perhaps I'll never know.

Beelzebub halts his fire-breathing. The flames from his mouth slow to a crawl and eventually disappear, but the rest of the room is still alight and burning like there's no tomorrow.

Satisfied, I tap into my mental connection. *Tvoorik, how many Kolvaxians are left?*

A tap on my shoulder. I turn back to see Cassiel, fright etched into every pore of her face. "Jason! It's terrible! Th-the sonic generators! During Bael's attack earlier, they were-

Tvoorik's voice appears in my mind. *Just one is left.*

The pieces click into place.

"Oh no."

Cassiel nods, and Samantha walks up behind her, a solemn expression visible. "It's already gone. It burrowed past our defenses. Tvoorik didn't notice due to the chaos, but we might be able to track and stop it before it does any damage."

My mouth tastes like chalk. "Yeah. Yeah, maybe, Sam."

No. She's wrong. We knew from the start that just one Kolvaxian let loose in the Labyrinth could spell our end.

We've lost.

Everyone stares vacantly at each other. Even Beelzebub's usual cockiness isn't there. Instead, he rights himself and scuffs his boot on the ground. "Damn."

From behind, a cheerful voice speaks out. "Oh hey! Great news!" Alpha jogs over to us, a sunny smile on his face, due to his total obliviousness.

I cough. "What... what news, Alpha?" I'm not ready for his stupidity right now.

Alpha holds a device in his hands. It's the detonator for the Spine Mines.

"You're not going to believe what that little scamp has stuck in his chest!"

It takes me a moment to register his words.

"Say what now?"

Part 486c: Cache, Money, Dough

Beelzebub nudges a rock on the ground with his foot. Based on its texture and design, it must have broken off from the ceiling. A sour look spreads from one corner of his mouth to the other. "Devils. What a mess. I should have come sooner."

Samantha leans against me and yawns. "Why didn't you?"

"I thought the humans could handle a few of the monsters. I was wrong." Beelzebub reaches up and slicks his hair back. A few hairs are noticeably singed and smoking from his fire-breathing earlier, but otherwise, his rich black hair is as immaculate as ever. "What are we to do now? There are thousands of portals to other worlds. Most of them reside in pocket dimensions, but the Volgrim installed the rest. The Kolvaxians will likely know of their existence."

His tone of voice makes me raise an eyebrow. His confidence from before is gone. Despite crushing every Kolvaxian that entered the Labyrinth, he's beginning to realize that the invasion has scarcely started, and we only won due to favorable circumstances.

"I can answer that," Ben says, as he and Cassiel stroll up to us. "Right now, there are still many Volgrim worlds out there. Melkin has fallen, but the Volgrim number in the tens of trillions across their remaining planets and sectors. If we can establish a base of operations, along with a new homeworld, then move them to it and form a defensive network, the Kolvaxians won't be able to penetrate it, and we can start pushing back against the monsters."

Cassiel slumps over against my other side; fatigue etched into her face. It's only been a half-hour since we blew up the final Spine Mine, but the adrenaline from the victory has worn off faster than anyone could imagine. Now, two straight weeks of battle has caught up with everyone involved.

Except for Ben, but maybe that's because of his Hypersuit.

My cute angel yawns. "Ugh, I wish we could just take a day off to nap. Why do our new enemies have to be so tenacious?"

"Every moment we waste, another Volgrim world is likely to fall," Ben replies. "For the moment, you can get some rest, and I can work with Beetlejuice on which planet to-"

"Beelzebub," The First Emperor hisses. "How could you possibly butcher my name so badly?"

"Sorry. I'm a little tired," Ben says, not bothering to look at him. "Anyway, there are several good candidates, including one on the outer rim, opposite from where the Kolvaxians

originated. It will take them quite some time to control all of the Milky Way up to the planet I have in mind, so the Volgrim will be able to fortify it dramatically. However, without a mixed ground force and competent leadership there at all times, we're unlikely to resist an aerial assault. Kolvaxians typically start with planetary bombardment, then they send in the ground troops, like what you saw on Melkin."

Jason Alpha appears out of nowhere and leans on Beelzebub's shoulder nonchalantly as if he's been in the conversation the whole time. "Hmph. What happened on Melkin was hardly anything. You've only seen one type of Kolvaxian up to this point."

Beelzebub quickly pulls away and swats Alpha's arm off his shoulder, leaving the other me to stumble slightly before regaining his balance. The First Emperor doesn't comment on Alpha invading his personal space. "What do you mean by 'only one type?' How many are there?"

Alpha taps his lip thoughtfully. "Well, up to this point we've seen their shock troops, which are equivalent to drones. Honestly, they usually never need more than drones, because those are more than enough to overwhelm most defenses. It's once they release the modified vehicles and start Infection Runs that a planet loses the ability to resist. At this point, your safest bet is to hole up in the Labyrinth forever and pray they never find a way to this dimension."

"Retreating into the Labyrinth is unacceptable, even if we destroy the portals to the outside universe," Beelzebub says. "The Volgrim constructed several portals themselves. If the Kolvaxians have their knowledge, it's likely they will create new ones once they discover our plans. If they do that, there's no telling where they will appear in the Labyrinth."

Silence follows. Everyone considers the possibilities, though Samantha and Cassiel keep yawning over and over.

I volunteer an idea as the girls blink their eyes sleepily. "Before Alpha and I leave, we'll take some time to build new portals to a few important places, and we'll demolish the ones that are too dangerous to leave alone. We'll also create some new worlds inside folded dimensions that the Kolvaxians won't know about, just so the Volgrim have somewhere to live. I doubt you want them filling up your Labyrinth."

Beelzebub nods. "That's an acceptable compromise. You have a mental map of where the portals are located, correct?"

"Yup." Privately, I wonder how he knows that. He did live with me for several years, so the Crown's capabilities probably slipped out at some point.

Tvoorik's voice speaks out from the entrance of the room as he slowly walks over to us. "Several Volgrim worlds are under attack. We can't dawdle, no matter how tired we are."

Behind Tvoorik, his shadow-walker friend skulks, an unpleasant expression on his face. "You're about to fall over, Tvoorik. If you keep going without rest-"

"That can't be helped." Tvoorik cuts his friend off. "I know you mean well, Ylvusk, but I can handle myself. One of my new abilities is to draw thought-energy from others around me. I have much more vitality than before my mutation."

"If you say so," Ylvusk quickly counters. "You should still get some rest. You worked harder than everyone else during that battle."

Ben frowns at the newcomers. "Now hold on just a second. I'm sure tapping into the hivemind was exhausting, but many people gave their lives fighting the Kolvaxians over the past several days. Don't diminish their hard work."

"He didn't mean anything by it," Tvoorik says. He walks into our group, and I notice, perhaps for the first time, that he's slightly shorter than Samantha and Cassiel. Demon mutations are all over the place when it comes to height. "Let's not worry about semantics. Beelzebub, dispatch a Demon Duke and some lords to Portal 823. It connects to Odarius, one of the worlds the Kolvaxians are about to attack, which houses several key military installations. After that, you should-"

Beelzebub raises a hand. "Hold on just a moment. I've yet to state where my allegiances lie. I helped out here because the humans imperiled the Labyrinth with their incompetence, but I never said I would continue to do so. I have no guarantee you won't stab us in the back when demonkind least expects it."

Cassiel blinks and pulls away from me. "Hold on; you think we'll betray you? Why? You know just as well as I do that Samantha is trying to bring peace between humans and demons. Betraying you runs counter to our goals."

"You've done it once before," Beelzebub snaps. "Well, the human king did, not *you*, but my point stands. Elshard leads the humans, and I don't trust him."

With a sigh, Cass shrugs. "Unless you want us to install a new leader, I can't help King Elshard's opinions. Who would lead the humans anyway? Ben?" She gestures to Ben, and he immediately takes a step back, recoiling from the idea. "Jason? No, you'd hate it if Jason were the official leader. Besides, he has to leave." Scarcely have the words left her mouth, when she makes a sudden choking sound as if realizing what she said. Cass turns her head to look up at me. "You are leaving though, aren't you?"

I glance at Alpha. He nods imperceptibly. "Afraid so, Cass. Afraid so."

"Aw." She doesn't protest but does wrap herself around my arm a little tighter.

Beelzebub crosses his arms, closing up his body language in the process. "Cassiel. I won't help humanity unless you take over as their leader."

Immediately, Cass jerks her head up. "What? Huh?"

Beelzebub smirks. "I didn't stutter. Satan hated angels, to the point of desperation. Admittedly, I've held prejudices against them in the past, but I have yet to see you do one disagreeable thing to a demon. Everything I've seen you do, and the tales that my people in your city have told me, indicate you're an upstanding person of moral uprightness. *Especially* compared to King Elshard and Jason. If you don't lead humanity, I won't follow."

Everyone's jaw drops, including Alpha's.

I ask the question on everyone's mind. "You want Cassiel to lead humanity? Why?"

Cass nods along, and Beelzebub unfolds his arms and holds his palms up like he's weighing two options. "The better question is, 'why not?' After all, most humans and many demons look up to her. They're calling her the Divine Mother. She's a symbol of righteousness, and her power is without question. I recall her dealing a most grievous wound to Satan that forced him to flee when even you Wordsmiths couldn't. Demons respect power. Humans respect morality. These traits do not conflict, and she has them in abundance."

Beelzebub leans forward and waggles his finger. "I know you aren't one to seek your own self-interest, Cassiel, but you should look at the upside for yourself. Humans will pray to you en-masse, increasing your spiritual energy. The angels will no longer have to rely on leftover scraps of energy that the glowing Jason over there gave them millions of years ago. I'm certain, based on the qualities you've exhibited up until now, that you could even convince the Volgrim to join our alliance, and with the Angels on your side, you'll have a military diverse enough to stand up to the monsters at our doorstep."

Alpha raises his hand, as a kid in a classroom would. "A question. How do you know where the angels obtained their energy?"

"I've been reading," Beelzebub says flatly. He glares at Alpha, then pulls back and brushes some dust off his shoulder. "Frankly, Cassiel, there's no answer you should give other than 'yes.' You're the only one who can lead demonkind into battle that won't give me the shivers. I won't lose sleep if it's you."

"What about me?" Samantha asks. She rubs her eyes and stretches. "Are you implying you can't trust me?"

"Of course I can't. That much is a given. You killed Gressil and severely wounded Diablo. You're untrustworthy, and you know it."

Samantha puffs up her cheeks and flips her head away. "Hmph. Asshole."

I raise an eyebrow at Beelzebub. He's acting odd. I never imagined he would consider Cassiel trustworthy. Naturally, Beelzy's correct, but it's strange hearing *him* say it.

"I don't know..." Cassiel trails off. "I don't like that people are worshiping me. I don't think I'm leader material."

Beelzebub nods sagely. "Mmm, yes, I see. That's unfortunate. Well, then, I'll pull all the demons out of the war, and you can have fun losing against the Kolvaxians." He casually shrugs, as if to say *what can I do about it?*

Cassiel flinches, and guilt blankets her face. "Alright, geez. I'll do it. Gosh." She pokes me in the stomach. "What's his angle, anyway? I can't see why he wants me as leader."

"I think Beelzebub likes you," Samantha says dryly. "He's a lonely demon. No woman around."

"Yeah," Alpha chimes in. "He likes a good, strong woman."

Beelzebub facepalms. "This is what I get for being polite to insects."

Everyone chuckles lightly, and for once, the mood seems to lift. Even Beelzebub, despite his pretentious attitude, doesn't have a stick as far up his ass as usual.

"Hey. What's going on, here?" A female voice speaks up. I turn to look behind Beelzebub, over to where the portal was that the Kolvaxians were pouring through. Much like the rest of the room, the area surrounding the portal is in ruins, but standing atop one prominent piece of debris is a familiar figure.

Marie.

Alpha's smile vanishes as he spots her. "Bloody hell."

"Alpha? Did you do this?! I've had alarms screaming all over my base for almost an hour now!" Marie hops off the misshapen chunk of ceiling, and from behind her, a scaly lizard-like creature crawls over the debris and rises up to his full height, towering over her. She ignores him, and storms up to Alpha and shoves her finger in his face. "What the hell are you thinking?! You can't just destroy portals! I have jurisdiction here!"

"Yeah, yeah." Alpha rolls his eyes so hard I lose sight of his pupils. "It's not what you think, Marie. The Kolvaxians attacked, so we were forced to defend ourselves. They launched their assault on-"

"Kolvaxians?! What the hell are you talking about?" Marie's anger slips, and she shoots a glance at Cassiel, Samantha, and I. "And what are you three doing here? Last I heard, you were

running away from the Volgrim like little chicken-shits."

The reptilian monster lumbers over toward us and rests his clawed hand on her shoulder. "Lady Marie, there has been a great battle here. I smell beings I have never contacted."

Marie's expression softens, and she reaches up to her shoulder and rests her hand on the lizard-man's. "Yes, Kar, thank you."

"Kar?" I squint to examine the lizard more carefully. The name is the same as a lizard-man I once knew, but instead of green scales, this lizard is colored red. A transformation, perhaps? Possibly another gap in my memory? "Are you the same one I once knew?"

The lizard-man nods, and he closes his eyes. "Correct. I have since recuperated from my injuries."

"No thanks to you," Marie adds snidely. "But we're not here about that. Alpha, what are Kolvaxians?"

Alpha bows his head. "I don't think I can tell you."

"Oh, pish. There you go getting caught up in the rules again." Marie kicks a pebble. "The other Maries know to stay out of my business. Let's not dredge up the past."

"You allied with Satan," Alpha says. "We can't trust you with information on the multiverse."

"That was before he gained the power of Wordsmithing! This is now!"

Alpha and Marie begin shouting at each other, and the rest of us are cast aside and left to feel uncomfortable. Nobody has a clue what they're talking about. The best I can guess is that she was once a member of the Central Hub, but she was cast out for working with Satan, but why wouldn't they just kill her? Lord knows the little I've seen of Marie tells me she'd kill one of her other selves without hesitation.

"Okay, okay, break it up." Kar reaches down and uses each hand to push Marie and Alpha out of each other's faces. "Alpha. You were gone a long time. Marie stays secluded on Earth. We don't know what the state of the galaxy is, beyond what the three turtles told us a few months ago. The Kolvaxians smell dangerous."

Alpha glares up at the giant lizard-man, but sighs. "Gah. Now that Marie's curiosity is piqued, she'll just interrogate everyone here after I take Sparky and leave."

"Damn right," Marie says, as she smirks. "Stop wasting my time and tell me already."

* * *

Minutes pass.

Marie's eyes grow as big as saucers. "So, let me get this straight. Universe 10K has a parasitic power-absorbing alien infection that has ravaged their Milky Way with no signs of slowing down for over ten million years, and you allowed them to travel here due to your stupidity during the Energy Wars?!"

Beelzebub shakes his head. "Devils. It's worse than I thought."

Alpha nods sheepishly. "Yeah, it's entirely my fault. Dunno what to say."

Marie holds up her hand and ticks off a few fingers as she speaks. "The Volgrim are playing defense and losing, demons have no space combat capabilities, humans are millions of years behind the Volgrim as well, and the angels might have been useful if you had more than a handful of them, but you don't. I guess you're pretty screwed, aren't you?"

Ben sighs. "What a positive thinker."

"Marie has always been like this," Alpha says, "though I'd hoped several million years of the silent treatment would change things."

She waves off Alpha's words. "Well, it's a good thing I'm a genius unlike any that have ever lived- barring my other selves, of course. I've been quietly building up a stockpile in case the worst should happen. I just didn't count on 'the worst' being 'freaky aliens that devour minds,' so great job exceeding my expectations."

"Stockpile?" Ben echoes. "What sort of stockpile?"

"I anticipated that, at some point, humanity might need to stage a comeback. Perhaps the Volgrim would grow too big for their britches, or maybe the demons might end up with a particularly bloodthirsty Emperor and would start massacring the defenseless humans. And, so, I created a small armada below the surface of Earth." The corners of Marie's mouth curl up into a tight smile. "Just in case."

"I suppose the Central Hub will forgive you for your past, then. That's what you want to hear, right?" Alpha glares at her, but he doesn't offer much resistance beyond that. I can see the relief written all over his face. He's glad to hear that she planned ahead for an uncertain future.

Beelzebub taps his wrist. "As good as this news is, time is short. We should have left several minutes ago. You heard Tvoorik; the Kolvaxians will soon annihilate several Volgrim planets, and then all hope will be lost. We need to act quickly."

Marie nods. Her pretentiousness vanishes. "You're right. Inform Diablo that I'll transfer my armada wherever it's needed. Less talk, more action."

"I'm the First Emperor now," Beelzebub says with a grunt. "Diablo is a lord."

"Oh!" Shock runs down Marie's back. She lurches noticeably. "Good God! The standards for First Emperor have lowered dramatically since the last time I visited!"

"I'll kill you," Beelzebub hisses.

* * *

An hour later, after teleporting Beelzebub and Tvoorik to the designated portal, and everyone else back to Hero City, Cassiel pulls me aside. Surprisingly, it's raining in Hero City, a rare sight to behold.

"Jason. I have to tell you something."

I nod, as the rain trickles off a balcony on the palace overhang. "Uh, sure."

"It's about Samantha. Well, it's about me, too."

She waits for me to give her the go-ahead, so I continue nodding. "Right. What's up?"

"I want you to take Samantha along when you leave with Alpha."

Oh. I didn't expect her to say that. "Yeah, that's fine. I have to ask him first, though. I don't think he'll say yes."

A lump forms in Cass's throat. "I want to go, too, but I can't. I know that now. Beelzebub threw his demand at me, and if I turn him down, we won't be able to unite against the Kolvaxians."

Something in her voice is off. "There's more, right? It's not just about Beelzebub. You could turn him down anyway."

She fiddles around and wrings her hands together repeatedly. "I... I don't know. This universe is my home, you know? I was born and raised here. I want to be with you, but I don't want to leave, either. I'm selfish, and I know it, but now that I've met others of my kind- other angels, I mean..."

She's saying 'I' a lot more than usual, I note. "You're torn. You want to come along, but if you do, humanity will probably fall to the Kolvaxians, along with the Volgrim, demons, and angels." My words are not a question.

Cass bows her head. "I don't know how long you'll be gone. The last few months were torture. I kept fighting, thinking you had died and I would never see you again. As bad as I felt, Samantha was worse. She's hidden her feelings from you well, but she kept crying, and whenever we fought the Kolvaxians, she'd explode in rage and tear them apart. I'm worried that if you leave again, she'll go over the edge."

Worrying. "If you think that'll happen, I can press Alpha. If I demand it, he'll let her come along with me. However, have you asked her opinion yet?"

"Huh? N-no..."

Slowly, I reach over and pull Cassiel against my chest. "Imagine how Sam will feel if she thinks we left you behind in a hostile universe. She'd worry about you every day, just as much as she would worry about me if she stayed. The only acceptable answer is for both of you to come along, and that would make everyone in this universe fall to the Kolvaxians."

"Oh." Cass wraps her arms around me. "What am I supposed to do, Jason? I can't lead. I can't protect anyone. The only thing I can do is heal my allies and kill my enemies. A leader has to be smart, and she has to-"

"Stop, stop." I pull Cass away and gaze into her eyes. "Why do you say things like that? Don't you realize what you've accomplished? Elshard wasn't the one fighting the Kolvaxians off for two weeks; you were. Beelzebub may have pulled off a last-minute save, but you held on the whole time up to that point. You thought of the sonic generators, you used Tvoorik to coordinate the defense, and you kept soldiers from dying. You're more of a leader than you'll admit, and everyone knows it."

Cassiel trails her hand down my arm and grasps my palm. "I guess." She has awful self-esteem issues.

"Just do me a favor, Cass. Ask Sam whether she wants to go with me or stay here. Don't make decisions for her."

Cass pulls her hand from mine. "What are you going to do?"

"I have to help get this universe prepared for the defense before I leave. I'm going to talk with Alpha. He might have some ideas I haven't thought of yet. After all, he's been doing this a lot longer than us."

"Yeah, maybe," Cass says, though she sounds unconvinced. "Remember what I told you. I don't trust Alpha. Something about him is just... off. He's too casual when it comes to death and murder. He may look human, but I think his humanity was stripped away a long time ago."

Yeah, I think to myself. You're right about that.

"I'll keep an eye on him, Cass."

In the distance, the local church's bell tolls. *Gong. Gong. Gong.*

We didn't save everyone in the battle. Some soldiers won't be returning to their families tonight.

Part 487c: The Last Promise

Building the portal to Voldarius inside Hero City seems the safest option to me, but at the same time, it needs to be functional and reliable. For that reason, I am now standing outside the city limits of Hero City, in a flat expanse where not much is going on. I think that at some point I was going to turn this grassland into a food-production and farming area, but I never got around to it. We have other bubble-worlds for that, after all.

" **Mountain!** "

With a single word, the ground rises beneath me, pushing me into the sky like a man riding a surfboard atop a wave of rock. It only travels a few hundred feet before stopping, but that's all I need. " **Flatten. Portal.** "

I let my imagination go a little wild, and not only does a plateau form at the top of the mountain, but an interesting series of swirls and marks appear on the ground. They harden together to form something resembling a map of the universe, with galaxies and stars spread out, yet remarkably detailed compared to something I'd usually think about. Perhaps they're the result of the Crown?

The portal to Voldarius forms before me, circular, with an arch that surrounds the swirling blue energy that eventually coalesces into an image of what lies on the other side. However, my eyes lower to the ground, examining the images and markings of our galaxy and hundreds of others.

The Milky Way. It's hard to think about, given the scale of the universe, but has Alpha never traveled beyond the boundaries of our galaxy? What lies beyond the void? Does Andromeda harbor life? Might the Kolvaxians have come from there? Could an accident in 10K allowed them to travel to the Milky Way, and thus they exist in every universe?

I raise my eyes to the portal and shake my head. I can only hope that isn't the case. If millions, perhaps billions more of those horrors await us outside the confines of our galaxy, then Humanity has a dark destiny in our future.

Walking forward, I step through the gate to Voldarius. When I teleport to a new location, the instantaneous change of scenery is jarring, but walking through a portal is similar to passing through a door. The difference, however, is the subtle change in temperature, the manner in which I can go from fifty degrees to eighty degrees and feel the difference massage me like I was stepping out of an air-conditioned house into a warm summer's day. It isn't unpleasant, so I quite like it.

The field is the same as I remember. Swaths of land are set up to grow wheat and a bunch of other population sustaining foods. This spot is the exact place I last spoke with Dosenia when I visited with Cassiel and Samantha.

I squint carefully. The houses in the Residential Zone, or whatever it's called, are closer than I remember. The Volgrim probably had to construct more living space for all the scientists and engineers I sent here.

My body tenses up. I don't know Dosenia very well, but I can only imagine how angry she'll be with me after two and a half months of radio silence. She probably thinks I dumped the scientists here and skedaddled, leaving her to scramble and find accommodations for them. I don't even know what the native population is on Voldarius, so I'm unsure how much stress I put on their ecosystem.

"Jason?" Samantha's voice makes me flinch, and I spin to face her. She must have followed me through the portal.

"Geez, Sam. You startled me."

"Sorry!" She giggles nervously and slinks up beside me, hooking her arms around my right side. "You terrified half of Hero City's residents! Everyone thought the invasion had begun when they saw a massive hill of dirt expanding on the outskirts."

I blush. "Oops. I should have warned everyone first." I pause as I examine her face suspiciously. "How'd you get here so quickly?"

She bows her head guiltily. "Oh, I was kinda sorta following you around. You looked troubled, so I didn't want to bother you."

"Mhm. Stalker." I poke her stomach, and she snickers and pulls away slightly.

"Stop! I'm ticklish!"

"I know, that's what makes teasing you so funny."

There's an awkward pause as our smiles vanish. I don't know why, but it's like the air chills between us for no reason. Despite this, she tightens her grip on my arm.

"So... Jason."

"Uh huh?"

Sam blushes. "I talked with Cass an hour ago."

"Mmm. Is that so?"

For me, it was several hours ago when I spoke with her. I had to take time afterward to coordinate our exhausted forces, strengthen their resolve with Wordsmithing, build a

temporary dimension to house millions of soon-to-be-displaced Volgrim refugees from the core worlds, and a whole bunch of other energy-taxing things. Naturally, Alpha didn't help me. He's incredibly lazy.

"Yeah. Cass said she tried to convince you not to leave, but you're going with Alpha anyway. Not only that, but you aren't taking us along with you!"

Oh. So that's why Sam wants to talk. I gaze into the distance at the Volgrim city and nod. It can wait. "Is that what Cass told you? I want to take you along. I'm going to beg Alpha to let me. The problem is, I don't think he will, and I don't have a way to force him."

Samantha smiles giddily. "You are? Wow! I can't believe Cass fibbed like that!" Her smile falters. "But... if Cass leaves, what does that mean for humanity?"

I chuckle. Funny, Sam has always had a soft spot for humans. It makes sense she'd worry about their safety. "They'll probably die, I suppose."

Her expression turns grim. "Y-yeah. Beelzebub is powerful, but he doesn't inspire courage-not like Cass, at least. Benjamin is amazing, and a great warrior, but you can see defeat in his eyes. He forces bravado for everyone else's sake. He's a broken man."

I reach over and caress Sam's face. Her skin is soft, a reminder of the nights we've shared, and the feelings I hold for her. "I know what you mean. I'm torn. Alpha tells me that if we go to the future, we can return and less than a day will pass. The problem is that he's screwed up twice already. If something goes wrong and we can't return in time..."

Samantha steps in front of me and holds my hands. "If Cass and I go with you, then we'd depend on Alpha to return us to the proper time. If he fails, the universe could be in ruins. Everyone we know will die. I don't want that to happen."

I force a smile for her sake. "What, you care about the people here? I thought you only liked me."

"And Cass!" Sam smirks. "But yes, I do care about other people here. Even if I didn't, I know Cass does. She's soft-hearted, compassionate, caring... everyone loves her. Even so, if push comes to shove, she'll violently protect the ones around her with her last breath. That's why they call her the Divine Mother, you know. She's a lioness."

Yes, my mind murmurs. A lioness. Cass keeps her 'pride' safe, and while she may not like violence at all, she's willing to jump in and fight tooth and nail to protect those she loves.

A memory bubbles up in my mind, as though it were from another universe or another time. Gressil cackles and takes a menacing step toward me, only for Cassiel to blast him with a level of energy rivaling the one she used to send Satan scurrying away. Gressil's body vaporizes into

dust, and Cassiel smiles at me, proud that she was able to protect me from the scary monster who once tormented her.

Did this vision happen? Is it merely a figment of my imagination? Perhaps I'm projecting Samantha's actions onto Cassiel and calling it a 'memory.' I'm probably going crazy.

"You're right, as always, Sam. Even if I want Cass to come with me, she won't. She says that Beelzebub is forcing her to stay and lead humanity, but that isn't the truth."

"Mmm." Samantha pulls away from me and runs a hand through her long, black hair. "So... if I go with you, then that means Cass has to stay behind, all by herself."

"Yup."

There isn't a way to soften the blow. Samantha has to choose: Cassiel, or me?

"This sucks," Sam says, as she exhales audibly. "If I go with you, that means leaving Cass behind. Alpha's screwed up twice already, so we might not come back for years. Who knows what could happen to Cass in that much time." A shadow passes over her face. "Even in the last two months, so much happened when you weren't here. The Kolvaxians move like the wind, devouring everything they find. Everyone was on edge, thinking the Kolvaxians could tear through any portal to attack us. Cassiel was the only one who kept a clear head and stationed a few troops outside the portal to Volgarius. If she hadn't, the monsters would have entered the Labyrinth, and you wouldn't have anything left to find when you returned."

In the distance, a male Volgrim catches sight of us. A questioning look appears on his face, before he darts away, likely to alert others about our sudden appearance.

Since this happens behind Samantha, she doesn't notice it. I reach over and squeeze her shoulder. "Look, if you want to come with me, please do. However, if you want to stay with Cass, then you won't think about her and worry night and day. I'll be safe with Alpha, and you know as well as I do that he's all but invincible. I doubt Satan could dent him at this point, and that's saying something."

Sam nods. "I know, I know. Still, what if you disappear and don't come back? What if there's an accident and you die, but we never find out? What if-"

I cut her off before she can continue. The agony on her face is making my stomach churn. "Sam, Sam, that won't happen. I should be more worried about you and Cass than either of you about me. I can't stand the thought of leaving you girls behind in a hostile universe."

Samantha stands up a little straighter, and a look of determination appears, as though she's forcing it for my sake. "You don't have to worry about us, Jason. I wouldn't let anything happen to Cassiel, no matter what. I know she can be a little stubborn, and that could get her into

trouble, but I won't let her jump in front of a monster to save others. If something happened to her..."

"Don't even talk like that." I pull Sam close, as more Volgrim appear in the distance. My hand roves across her back, and the smell of her hair intoxicates me. "Nothing's going to happen to you or Cass. If Alpha can't return us to the right time, I'll do it myself. No matter what."

Sam's fingernails dig into my back. "Promise?"

"Promise."

She nods, and her face rubs against my chest. "No takebacks."

"I wouldn't dream of it."

Satisfied, Samantha reaches up, pulls my head down, and kisses me. Her tongue has a mind of its own. She ravishes my mouth for several seconds, and I return the gesture, almost daring her to probe further.

However, she pulls away, grumpiness written all over her face. "Ugh. I hate getting interrupted."

My mind is so foggy from her pheromones that it takes me a second to shake the sensation off and realize what she's talking about. The Volgrim from earlier are much closer, perhaps a few hundred feet away. I recognize the leader immediately. *Dosena*.

Her group of fifty slows to a stop. Dosena scowls at us and speaks, irritation in her voice. "I apologize for bothering you during your primitive mating ritual. Don't stop on my account."

Samantha's eye twitches as she turns to face the newcomer. "That's no way to talk to friends."

"Friends," Dosena echoes dryly. "You've been gone for nearly a hundred orbital cycles. The refugees were supposed to be temporary. For an ally, you left us with a huge burden."

I interrupt Sam before she turns hostile. "Ah, haha... that's my fault. There was an accident and I time-traveled. Sorry won't cut it, I know, but I'm here now!" I chuckle uneasily, crossing my fingers that Samantha doesn't say anything to piss Dosena off. *We need her talents, Sam. She can lead the Volgrim more effectively than any of us.*

It takes a moment, but Dosena calms down. "Ah, well, at least you returned after all. Why are you here now?"

I swallow a lump in my throat. "You remember what I told you about the Kolvaxians?"

Dosena raises an eyebrow. "What of them?"

"They took over Melkin. We were forced to destroy the planet to contain the infection... and soon they will destroy the rest of Volgrim civilization."

Several Volgrim behind her flinch, and I recognize one or two of them. *Scientists from Melkin*, my brain hints, as it fills in the gaps. The Volgrim may attempt a blank facade for their emotions, but hearing about the destruction of their homeworld, for the *second time* at that, is going to affect them negatively, no matter how they try to hide their emotions.

"By the Founders..." Dosena curses under her breath and rubs her hands together. She turns to stare silently at one of the nearby Melkian scientists, before turning back to me. I surmise that she must have spoken to him telepathically. "Would you care to fill me in on what's happened during your absence?"

"It would be my pleasure."

Part 488c: Abandoned

Everyone's gone, now. My fingers tick off the checklist as I count off items in my head.

Ben is probably at the portal already, sending men and women to save the Volgrim worlds. I established a new portal system inside Hero City, so putting the Volgrim inside their nearly limitless pocket dimension should protect them from the Kolvaxians. Check.

Beelzebub, to his credit, is keeping his word and sending demons to assist the fleeing Volgrim as they pour into the Labyrinth. Check.

After explaining the situation, Dosena begrudgingly agreed to help out. Having spoken with others of her kind, she knows the Volgrim leadership was wiped out by the Kolvaxians, and even if the new Volgrim are different from the old, she's still a leader at heart.

...Check.

I think I'm finished. Other than staying behind and fighting alongside my friends and comrades, I have no reason to stay here anymore.

Yet, at the same time, I feel empty. I'm only leaving because Alpha won't take 'no' for an answer. I don't want to go. I want to stay with Samantha and Cassiel. Alpha should investigate his own bullshit. It has nothing to do with me.

I want to punch something.

The emptiness of the castle around me looms like a graveyard. Nobody is here now. Every military commander and noble are doing their part to ensure the survival of the Volgrim, salvage as much technology as possible, and seal the portals before the Kolvaxians make landfall. From what I've heard, three Volgrim worlds are currently under siege. Nobody will tell me anything since Cassiel ordered them not to rile me up. She knows that the more I hear about the situation, the more likely I'll fight Alpha to the death for my right to stay.

Shitty. That's what this is.

I lean against a pillar and tap my wrist. Alpha was supposed to be here an hour ago, yet he makes me wait for no reason. First, he makes everything sound like we're under awful time constraints, then he gets all huffy and storms off, and now he takes his sweet time, as if I didn't already have enough reason to stay.

Fuck it. Fuck it!

I'm not going to wait anymore. Yeah. Yeah! I'm going to teleport to Cassiel, stay by her side, and tell Alpha 'up yours!' Something's wrong with that guy, anyway. Cassiel's a bloodhound

when it comes to danger detection.

Footsteps. I tilt my head up and look around, but in the giant hall just inside the palace doors, the acoustics turn every sound into a distant echo. I can't tell what direction the footsteps are coming from.

A half-minute passes and I keep looking around, until finally, I spot the figure. King Elshard.

No, not a king. Cassiel demoted him. He was very gracious about it, too.

Cody Elshard casually strolls over but doesn't smile. "Haven't left yet, have you?"

"No. I'm waiting on that other Jason."

"Mmm." Cody glances around the hall. "I hope you don't fight with him. Rebuilding the palace after the Clone Wars was bad enough the first time. We don't have troops or workers to spare, now."

"Yeah..." I trail off thoughtfully. "I hear you're not a king anymore."

"So they say," He replies dismissively. "I ruled for a short time. I was ineffective. I couldn't stop the demons, and I cannot fight these new monsters. The people have no faith in me, but they believe in the winged one."

"Cassiel," I state rhetorically. "I hear you didn't offer a word of protest. Why not?"

His eyes glaze over. "I don't believe in myself."

"What? You don't?"

He shakes his head. "As I said, I was a failure. I couldn't protect my comrades from dying at the hands of the demons. Saul... Gunther... even Adams. Samantha is the last one of my squadmates alive, and she hates me."

I crinkle my nose. "Oh, come on, Cody. Sam doesn't hate you. That's ridiculous."

He nods. "She does. I locked up all the demons in this city and even accused her of- well, you know. You were there. She saved my skin several times and helped fend off the Grez, and I repaid her with a slap to the face. I'm an ingrate."

I want to tell Cody something comforting like, *no no, it's all in your head, don't worry about it*, but he has a point.

My feet shuffle around, and Cody scratches a sore on his neck. He winces in pain, so I use the interruption to reply. "I don't think she hates you, but if you haven't apologized already, it's never too late to try."

Cody lightly kicks the pillar. "Yes, perhaps I should."

An awkward silence fills the air between us. After a few moments, Cody turns to leave, but stops. "Oh. Your clone is here."

He points across the hall, and I turn to see Alpha striding toward us from the palace's entrance. The look on his face is grim, and I realize why as I spot the person beside him: Marie.

Her expression could curdle milk. Cody, seeing the unpleasant woman striding toward us, nudges me. "Take care, Jason. Stay safe during your travels."

I nod in response, and the former king trudges away in the opposite direction that Alpha and Marie are coming from, deeper into the castle.

Once Marie is closer, she glances suspiciously at Cody's back, but eventually stops caring and turns to me. "Oh good, you're here on time. At least you're punctual."

"Punctual? What about you?!" I turn to Alpha. "What took you so long? Why is she with you?"

Alpha withstands the barrage of questions like a mountain would against a gentle tide. "There's been a change in plans. Marie's coming with us."

This catches me by surprise. "Uh, okay. But why?"

Marie scowls. "Are you looking a gift horse in the mouth? I gave your girlfriends an armada that I had spent several million years building up under Earth's surface just so they would have a fighting chance. I'd like a bit of gratitude."

She reaches in her shirt pocket and pulls out a cigarette, then lights it with a hidden lighter I didn't notice before. As she puffs on it, I rub the back of my head. "Right, I'm very thankful for that. I don't see what your armada has to do with anything, though."

"It's- well, it's a tit-for-tat thing," Alpha clarifies, "since she did give us a sizable fleet of very powerful ships to defend this universe, she expects some quid-pro-quo."

I'm stunned. I can barely believe my ears. "Marie! There were strings attached?! I thought you gave those ships because you wanted to protect your own skin, at the very least! If the Kolvaxians take over the galaxy-

"It wouldn't affect me in the slightest," She says, cutting me off mid-sentence. "Anyway, it has nothing to do with you. This development has been a long time coming. Perhaps with this, I can get access to the Marie Council once again."

To say I'm confused would be an understatement. Why does she want to be on the council? Why did they kick her off originally, other than her alignment with Satan in the distant past? I don't know much about her, but if working with the First Emperor is cause enough to kick her

off, I don't see why they'd let her back on over something like this. Then again, I don't know anything about Maries beyond the few instances I've talked with one of them.

Alpha replies before I can. "Remember, Marie 19A, I made no promises. I only said I'd ensure they looked into your file. If they suspect you of some plot to destroy the Central Hub, my hands are tied."

She blows smoke in the air and tilts her head away from both of us. "I know that much, imbecile. I'm not stupid. You'd think millions and millions of years of good behavior would make my sisters more lenient, especially if they're as low on womanpower as I think they are."

Now it's Alpha's turn to be visibly confused. "How do you know about the staffing situation?"

A slight smile appears on her face as she jerks her head back to examine him. "I didn't, but I do now. Manipulating you to give me information is like taking candy from a baby. Now, are we going to sit here and blabber all day, or are we going to leave?"

"You're obnoxious," Alpha says with a scowl. At least we both can agree on that much. "I'm beginning to remember why they cast you aside."

Her smile slips. "Don't act sanctimonious with me. You think I was the only one who allied with Satan? I came to this universe to replace Marie 12B. You know, the Marie you *crushed to death with a boulder*. My orders were to replace her and continue maintaining this universe as best as I could. Once you became an all-seeing Thoughtsmith, the other Maries cowered and distanced themselves from Satan, but they used me as a scapegoat! They set me up!"

Alpha reaches up to rub the bridge of his nose. "Right, right. The fact you still hold a grudge won't do you any favors with the Council. It's water under the bridge at this point."

Marie rolls her eyes. "Exactly the response I'd expect from a troglodyte."

Oh, brother. These two are going to fight the whole time, aren't they? I curse silently, wishing I could shut their mouths off for a while. I suppose deafening myself is an option. Wordsmithing truly is a magical thing.

Alpha rubs his hands together. "Alright, enough wasting time." He snaps his fingers, and a moment later, a portal forms, allowing Harold to step through.

The portal closes behind him, and the old man slaps Alpha on the back. "All righty! We 'bout ready to git the heck outta here?"

I glance around. "Wait, we can't go yet. I'm waiting on Samantha."

Alpha raises an eyebrow. "Why?"

"He needs a quickie for the road; I'd wager," Marie jokes.

I resist the urge to hit her. "Samantha hasn't told me her choice yet. I asked her if she wanted to come along."

Alpha answers almost immediately. "It's a no-go. I asked Belial, and she said she was staying behind. Something about... Cassiel's future." An odd look in Alpha's eye makes me double-take.

"She told you that, but didn't tell me?" I stare at him in disbelief. "I... I can't believe Sam would do that."

Alpha pauses hesitantly, as if he's debating his words. "Belial probably just didn't want to face you after turning you down. You know how women can be."

My foot scuffs on the floor. All three of the others stare, waiting for me to give up. "If I leave both of them behind, and something happens, I'll never forgive myself."

Quickly, perhaps *too* quickly, Alpha spits out, "No no, don't worry about it. Central Hub is probably going to dispatch a Jason or two here. It'll be plenty safe."

Harold holds up his wrist and the smart-watch gadget on it. "Helen's stayin' behind too, kid. S'long as she has her temporal communicabobber, she can send a ping, and I'll catch it! We can pop back in a jiffy if somethin' happens!"

Alpha relaxes. "Yeah, what Harold said. There's nothing to worry about. Let's stop dawdling and get a move on."

Hesitating, I glance at the doorway to the palace, half-expecting her to come running through it. She won't, of course. I'm acting like a child.

Finally, I relent. "Okay. Do it."

"Took him long enough," Marie mutters under her breath.

"Synchronize our position, Harold," Alpha says, as he breathes a sigh of relief. *He's glad I'm not putting up a fight anymore*, I muse to myself.

The old man taps his watch, and a holographic display hovers above it. For several moments, he taps on the panels floating in midair. His face tenses up as he presses buttons.

Impatience appears on Alpha's face. "Is it that glitch again?"

Harold nods. "It's the damnedest thing, kid. Stupid gizmo has a mind of its own."

"Glitch?" I ask. "What glitch?"

Alpha laughs nervously. "W-well, you know how I told you we could pop back a minute after we left, but instead we showed up two and a half months later?"

"Uh-huh."

He continues. "The thing is, that *used* to be the case. There's been weird interference with our synchronizers for several thousand jumps. Marie Alpha and her whole R&D division can't pinpoint the problem."

I feel my fists clench up. "You mean to tell me... you knew we wouldn't be able to return when you said we could? You lied to me?"

"N-not, a lie." Alpha chuckles again. "Technically, we could, it's just really difficult because of the syncing glitch. I have to over-compensate if I feel distortion lag."

Marie leans against a pillar. "Wow. And here I thought the Central Hub was supposed to be smart. Maybe I'm not missing out on anything important after all."

Harold rolls his eyes. "Ding-damn, woman. Everything has a bug or two 'n it. 's not a big deal at all. Let the ladies at HQ do their jobs 'n they'll fix it eventually." He pauses. "I hope."

Once again I'm left to smolder and choke on my anger. Not only did Alpha know that we probably couldn't return 'a minute later' like he said, but he also lied to me about it. I hate liars. Can't turn my back on them. If he lied once, who's to say he won't lie about other things?

"Mmm. There we go, I think," Harold says, as he closes off his holographic display. "Okay, kid. Do your thing."

Alpha smiles cheerfully at me. "Okey dokey, here we go!"

My teeth grind together as I force a smile. "Yeah. Here we go."

The world changes around us. For a split second, I can almost hear a voice calling out to me, but it's probably nothing. Just my imagination.

* * *

I'm late! Shoot, I should have run faster! I had to stop to take care of some wounded soldiers, but I know Jason won't fault me for that.

Devils! How long was I tending their wounds? Ten minutes? Twenty? After I leave with Jason, Cassiel will have to do all the healing herself. I have to help while I still can.

The hallways of the Labyrinth are a blur as I press my feet against walls and rush forward at incredible speed. Thankfully, with humans and demons pouring all their energy into the war-efforts, there's nobody in my path to slow me down. I can move as fast as possible!

The Labyrinth opens up around me to reveal the outpost that leads to Hero City. I slow to a halt and quickly show the guards my ID, and they let me pass with more than a cursory glance at my body, but I ignore them and press onward. Their gaze means nothing to me.

Once inside the portal, I glance around. Only a mile to go! I'm practically there! The palace looms in the distance, and I glance up at the star in the sky. 6:30? Maybe 7:00? I can't tell! This planet, like all other ones, has its own timescale, and I'm still not used to it.

Either way, I'm late. I know that much!

I take several shortcuts, leap over walls in a single bound, breathe a sigh of relief at how few soldiers there are in the city.

The palace grows bigger as I approach, and my heart flip-flops. *He's still there! He has to be!* He promised me he'd beg and plead with Alpha to let me come with him. I told him I might stay, but there's no way he'd leave me behind without a definite answer!

Another shortcut. I'll have to enter through the rear of the palace. A thirty-foot wall protects it, but I can clear that with ease. Indeed, I make a forty-foot hop and barely use any energy at all. Landing on the ground, I stumble a little as my bare feet smush into a soft patch of dirt. My body loses control, and I tumble forward, face-first, but catch myself before I taste soil.

It takes a second for me to pull myself up, but when I do, I spot King Elshard sitting on a bench, staring at me in surprise. No, that's wrong. He's not a king anymore. I don't think he's even a noble.

Elshard waves at me nervously. "O-oh! Samantha! Uh, hello?"

I nod at him quickly. "Cody." I glance past him at the rear entrance. "Have you seen Jason?"

He blushes slightly, and I realize my top must have shifted slightly. "Err, yes. He's, uh, inside the- well, the palace. Near the front."

"Oh, great. Thanks!" I start to take off, but Cody jumps to his feet.

"Wait! Uh, S-Samantha..."

Irritation passes over my face. I don't care about what he has to say. Jason's waiting for me!

Then again, I'm about to leave this universe, possibly for a very long time. I can't just leave bad blood behind.

"What?"

He rubs his hands together sheepishly. "I need to apologize to you. For everything. I've been not only a terrible ruler, but a terrible friend."

"It's fine, it's fine," I say, quickly brushing him off. "Don't even worry about it."

"You and I are the last, you know," He says, quickly. "The last of our squad. Gunther and Saul are both gone. So are the others."

His words make me pause. "Yes, I suppose that's true."

Cody flinches, as if an imaginary fist is about to hit him. "Do you hate me?"

"For what?"

"For putting demons in camps. For insulting you after you went off with Jason for a few months. For all the things I've done."

While I *am* late, he has a point. "I don't hate you. At worst, I felt betrayed, but I got over it. Demons tried to kill you. You coped in the worst way possible, but no permanent damage was done. Honestly, you could have caused plenty more harm."

Relief swells up in his eyes. "Oh... that- that means a lot, coming from you."

I take a hesitant step toward the door. "Um, I'm glad I could help you feel better, Cody."

He nods quickly and wipes his eyes. *Tears?* "Yeah, thank you, Sam. I've been going through a lot of emotions today."

Devils. I feel bad leaving him like this, but...

"Take care, Cody." I force a smile and dash away, nearly tearing the flimsy oak door off its hinges. Sometimes when I'm in a rush, I forget my strength!

The halls blur past as I rush toward the front entrance. *Damn! Why did it have to be on the wrong side of the palace?!*

"Jason! Jason!" I yell for him, unsure where to look.

Voices in the distance. "-we go!"

Go? Go where? My heart skips a beat. They're right at the front door! Move, legs!

"Jason!" I come into view of the four of them, right as they vanish. Just before they disappear, I catch a glimpse of his face. His eyes lower, and incredible anger fills his gaze. I'd know that look of his anywhere.

And, just like that, they're gone. Four people. I barely noticed the other three.

I slow to a walk and stumble over to where they were just standing. "Jas...on?"

He's gone. I'm too late.

He left without me.

Why? Why would he leave? I thought he was going to wait.

Oh. That's right. He looked angry before they jumped. Was it because of me? Was he angry that I didn't show? No, that can't be it. He'd know I was busy, right?

Or... maybe he didn't. Maybe he thinks I chose Cass over him. But... but I didn't. I didn't!

Why would he be angry?! I don't understand!

My knees tremble, and I slump to the ground. *He left without me, and it's all my fault. I should have been here sooner. I'm a floozy! I'm stupid!*

It's all my fault.

Part 489c: Paradox

A harsh metallic smell greets us as we arrive. A sickening sensation, as if we've landed on a ship in the middle of the ocean riding out a storm, courses through my insides. After a moment it passes, and I kneel down to regain my balance.

"That was a rough one," Alpha comments dryly.

Teleporting always jars me, but this is nothing like when we visited the Central Hub. It's almost as though something tore out a piece of my soul, then jammed it back inside my body.

After a moment, I stand back up and look around. We're inside a muggy bar, where the air smells like iron, and a taste similar to sulfur rests on my tongue, growing thicker every breath I take. Tables line up against the walls and throughout the middle, and way off on the other end, perhaps fifty feet away, a bartender leans his arm on the bar and snores quietly. No other people are here with us.

"Nice place you picked," Marie quips. "Classy. If ever I were to describe the smell of Satan's rectum, this would be it."

Alpha's eye twitches. "Harold, this is the spot, right?"

The old man nods and brings his watch up to activate its holographic display once again. "Yeap. Marie 12F said this'd be a safe area for Travelers to pop in. We're just a few levels above Earth's surface."

"Huh." Alpha pinches his nose. "Cripes. What's up with the smell? Marie has a point."

Harold shrugs. "I can ask the Hub if they'll send some data, son. We ain't never been to this stream before."

Alpha nods slowly. "Yeah. Supposedly it's a Source."

Source? Before I can ask him what that is, irritation appears on Harold's plasticine face. "Son of a gun. You ain't gonna believe this."

"Oh, come on... what now?" Alpha sighs overdramatically and leans over to look at Harold's display. "Again?"

"Mhm. We're later than expected. God-damned busted temporal crap put us months in the future. We've gotta message the Hub so they know we missed the arrival point."

"The future?" I pause to consider this. "Wait, if we're in another universe's future... doesn't that mean we could screw their timeline up just by being here?"

Alpha wants to ignore me but decides against it. "Not really."

I don't believe him. "But if we're in the future, then doesn't that mean returning to my universe and time will cause a paradox? A split reality? Two streams of time? A butterfly effect?"

"The heck do butterflies hafta do with anything?" Harold asks. "That's gotta be the dumbest thing I ever done heard."

Alpha nods. "Yeah, it's no big deal. Time probably split when we arrived, but that happens all the time."

Marie pulls out a lighter and cigarette, glaring at me as I turn to her. "Don't even bother. I couldn't care less about your questions."

"I didn't ask you anything."

She stuffs the cigarette in her mouth and lights it with a flourish. "Yeah, but you were going to."

She's a dead end. I turn back to Alpha, who is now pulling out a chair at a table beside us and plopping down, evidently waiting for Harold to finish up something on his wrist-projector thing. "Alpha, what do you mean by 'time splits?' What does that even mean?"

Alpha rolls his eyes. "Well, whenever we travel through time, and occasionally to other universes, there's like, a split in the timeline. Another universe forms from the old one."

"Uh huh..."

He resists my prodding for a second but continues. "Well, imagine if a universe was traveling along its path to a destination we'll call 'X,' but then you, an outsider appeared. Since you will alter its trajectory, it changes course and reroutes to destination Y. A new universe emerges that continues to the original destination."

"That sounds ominous," I mutter, as I pull up a chair at the same table. "Yet you think it won't cause a paradox?"

"Pft, nah," Alpha says, smirking, as he leans his neck back against the chair and props his head up with his hands. "Unless you do some really crazy shit, universes merge back together almost a hundred percent of the time. No paradoxes."

"Oh," I say, not entirely convinced. "Well, you know more than I do, obviously. A hundred percent sounds good."

Several moments pass. Alpha closes his eyes and tries to relax, but his face tightens. "Well, okay, it's more like ninety percent of the time."

"Ninety," I echo. "So... a ten percent chance of failure."

He opens his eyes and stares at the ceiling. "Ehh, give or take ten or twenty percent. Pretty close to that."

I want to choke him to death. "That's a giant margin of error, Alpha."

He leans forward in his seat again, then waves his hand dismissively. "Man, it's no big deal. The Marie Council's got all that boring stuff under control. There are plenty of other Jasons who can take care of splits if push comes to shove."

"If you say so."

My throat is as dry as sand. I consider bugging the bartender for a drink, only to remember I have Wordsmithing. " **Milk.** "

A glass of ice-cold milk appears on the table before me. As I raise it to my lips, I notice Alpha squinting at me. "What? Got a problem?"

He looks away and shakes his head. "No. I just didn't picture you as someone who'd like... milk. Weird."

"What, you don't?"

He taps his lip thoughtfully. "No... I do. That's what's weird. Other Jasons I've met don't."

Alpha gives an inordinate amount of thought to my beverage, as he stares at a wall to his right blankly. Silently, I sip the milk, and its coolness soothes my aching tonsils. Whatever's in the air, it's frigging corrosive.

From our left, Harold clears his throat. "Hah-hum. Well, Central Hub sent me the info. It seems Marie 12F was all fired-up in this stream. She runs this place real good, keeps it in tip-top shape. She manages every part of society."

"Sounds like a nightmare to live in," Alpha mutters.

"The smog ain't very nice. That's probably the stench you guys're smellin'." Harold winks at me, though I'm not sure why. "Anyway, we're in the bottom levels of a big-ass skyscraper. This timeline's super advanced, she calls them 'stratoscrapers' 'n 'megascrapers.' They damn near reach Earth's atmosphere."

Marie 19A crosses her arms and leers toward the doorway. "Meh. I could do better."

"Just what I'd expect a Marie to say," Alpha grunts. "You know the situation now, right, Harold?"

"Mhm." Harold points straight above us. "We've gots ta' get up ta' the upper levels. That's where all the rich 'n powerful folks live."

While he and Alpha debate the next step of our plan, I glance to my right and spot a gigantic TV covering the entire wall. Only a small portion in the middle is playing something, but if it were expanded, it would put some movie theaters I've seen to shame. The volume is muted, but words crawl across the bottom of the screen.

An Asian-looking guy dressed in a sharp suit stares at the camera, and behind him plays a sweeping visual of several people milling about in the stands of an indoor amphitheater.

The news host nods at the camera. *David Finch and Caroline Watters are on the scene with other reporters as they gather for the Supreme Commander's speech. Caroline, tell us what the Commander is going to talk about today.*

The camera cuts to a man and a woman standing a short distance from the people in the background. The woman is wearing a plain, functional blouse, and her lips are painted ruby-red with several layers of lipstick. She's very prim and proper, giving off a professional image.

My pleasure, Kenji. As you know, our Supreme Commander has pushed through a host of legislative actions over the past year, some of which have angered critics and infuriated activist groups, including those who represent equal rights for the lower levels. While we do not know precisely what he will be talking about in his speech today, it is very likely that he is planning to address these criticisms, and will hopefully offer a response regarding complaints of governmental abuse. He has been met with 120 consecutive days of protests, so it's improbable he can continue to ignore the issues forever.

Her fellow reporter shuffles his feet and waits for an idle moment to jump in. When she pauses to take a breath, he spots his chance. *It's like Caroline says, Kenji. With the suicide rate increasing by 10,000% in just the last year, many middle-level and low-level officials are extremely worried about the possibility of that trend skyrocketing unabated. If the Supreme Commander has any compassion for those other than the upper 1%, we have yet to see him demonstrate it.*

"Sparky. Hey." Alpha snaps his fingers and pulls me back to reality. "Let's go." He's already standing up. I was so engrossed in this otherworldly news report that I didn't even notice.

"Go? Where?" I quickly stand up and follow him as he heads for the door.

"I don't know, exactly. We're long past the date where we were supposed to meet with Marie 12F. I'm considering teleporting to the Central Hub and picking her up there, but maybe Harold's internal data is enough for now. We're just here to investigate this other Jason, after all."

As he and I catch up to Marie 19A and Harold at the door, she snakes a few ornery strands of hair behind her ear. "If we have to find the Jason of this stream, do you have the faintest clue

where to look?"

Alpha nods. "There are, or were, two Jasons here. This stream is suspected of being a double-Source stream- very worrying. The first Jason is Jason 12F. He was supposedly killed by the second Jason, who Marie Alpha has designated 'Jason X.' His origins are a mystery, but based on memories taken from Jason X's mind-

I hold my hand up to interrupt him. "Uh, sorry Alpha, but you're losing me. All of this is going right over my head."

More irritation. Alpha rolls his eyes. "I was answering Marie, not you. Obviously, you don't understand the basics of time travel, so you won't be able to follow along."

Marie opens the door, and as we walk through, I clench my fist. "Can't you just answer one little question without looking down on me? Five minutes would do wonders to explain what's going on."

We step into a musky corridor, one where the air is a little smoky and hard to see. There's a pungent taste in the air, like rotten fruit tossed into a roaring fire then pulled out after a few second and served on a platter.

Alpha shrugs. "Fine, fire away. What's your first question?"

His sudden reversal takes me by surprise. I stifle my gag reflex from the pungent air, and Harold takes the lead, walking down the hallway to an exit door. "What's a 'Source?'"

Alpha scrunches up his face. "I'm a Source. You're probably a Source. So are Jason 12F and X. To answer that question, I'd have to explain the multiverse and what caused it."

"Caused it?" I echo.

"Yes. I'm probably the reason we have a multiverse, since I'm the first Time Traveler. At least, that's what Marie Alpha says."

"I've thought the same thing," Marie 19A comments. She puffs on her cigarette and blows the smoke directly up into her nose, likely to try and smell less of the air around us.

"Mmm." Alpha clears his throat. "Anyway, I traveled back in time by speaking the word, 'Rewind.' When I did that, I created the first universe split. After several hundreds of years, I-" Alpha pauses mid-sentence and chokes up. I almost think it's because of the odor, but he touches his throat lightly before continuing. "I... lost someone dear to me. Several people, in fact. After many years, I decided to try and go back in time to undo a mistake I'd made. In the process, I made a huge mistake."

He doesn't continue. I wait for a few moments before prodding. "What mistake?"

Alpha shakes his head. "I'd rather not go into details. Suffice it to say; I underestimated the dangers of time travel."

A memory from a week ago comes to me. "You mean, the point where you nearly unleashed the Sentinels on the multiverse?"

Marie chuckles. "That's the one."

Alpha doesn't let his emotions slip. Light appears at the end of the hallway. It looks like we're about to enter an enclosed glass tube suspended in the air.

"Anyway. I time traveled several more times, jumping from point to point, not realizing the causality errors I was causing. At that point, the Central Hub contacted me. They began to explain the repercussions of my actions, but it was already too late. The damage was done."

Marie nods. "At that point, splits were happening regardless of his presence. We suspected there was another time traveler, and eventually found out it was Satan. He was still alive. Due to the nature of the multiverse, new streams don't appear linearly; they appear all at once. If you treat the Multiverse like a series of straight lines on a piece of paper, then they will all have different origin points, but anytime there's overlap in relative time, they exist in the same reference point."

Nodding along, I keep a thoughtful look frozen on my face. *I have no idea what the fuck they're saying*, I think to myself. "Does that mean the multiverse is expanding on its own?"

"Proly not," Harold drawls. "Sometimes it split, and sometimes the splits pop back together. Ever have a moment where people forget details 'bout the past? Maybe they misremember somethin' and jes' kinda shrug it off. That usually means two universes popped back together."

"They merge," Marie says, correcting the old man.

It takes me a moment, but a puzzle piece clicks into place. "Oh. You mean like *deja vu*?"

Alpha nods. He pauses before the exit, which turns out to be a spherical glass tube connecting our tower to one several hundred feet away. It's suspended in the air, and immediately my stomach lurches as I gaze through the transparent floor at the ground hundreds of feet below us. I can barely see, since the air outside is colored brown. It swirls around the tube like an underwater monster, begging for a chance to burst inside and devour us alive.

"Yes. *Deja vu* is a good descriptor. The Marie HQ was formed without my help, and she began monitoring the multiverse at some point before contacting me once she discovered I was causing most of the new universes to appear. By then, I didn't have a way to undo everything, so

we committed to tracking down other potential Wordsmiths. As far as we know, the only people with the ability to split streams are Satan, Hope, and myself."

"And your clones guarding the other universes?"

My friendly question is shot down by Alpha with a smirk. "I don't have many clones. I try to keep their numbers low. Most of the other Jasons are from streams split before my birth. At one point I went back in time to speak to Heroes from the past to trace my lineage. Unfortunately, this split the streams multiple times and gave birth to many versions of me who have lived lives very different from mine."

Alpha starts to step onto the glass floor, but Harold stops him. "New data, kid. Jason X is the Supreme Commander in this universe. If you'n Sparky go walkin' around, people are gonna recognize ya, 'n it could cause trouble."

"Cripes. You'd think Marie Alpha would've mentioned that." Alpha turns to look at me for a moment before facing the glass tube again. His body shifts, and I notice the side of his face tighten ever so slightly. At the same time, my skin crawls, like I have fire ants chewing on the nerves in my face. After a moment, the sensation disappears. Alpha sighs. "There. Now nobody will recognize us."

"Just one more thing to worry about," Marie mutters. "If Marie 12F runs this universe, why is Jason X the Supreme Commander?"

I rub my cheek and watch as Marie and Alpha fearlessly step onto the glass without a care in the world. Gingerly, I press a foot onto it, shivering as nausea hits me with a gut punch. I could easily save myself if the glass blew out. Hell, even without Wordsmithing, the body the Gods gave me could take a fall at terminal velocity without killing me. "Maybe it's a puppet thing. She makes him the public face, but she's behind the scenes and controlling everything."

Marie suddenly laughs out loud, startling me. "Hahaha! How appropriate! I hope that's the case! It's exactly the kind of thing I would do!"

It only takes us half a minute to cross over to the other skyscraper. My animal-brain sighs in relief once we're back on visible ground. As we cross over from the dead and lifeless Arrival building, we step into a veritable sea of people. They seemingly appear out of midair, hordes of them chattering to each other noisily and strolling from here to there, talking about this and that. One boy sits over against a wall pushing a small toy back and forth while his friends laugh and comment about banal things in their imaginary play session.

The clothes people wear are noticeably cheap and lackluster. Several people cough a little or a lot, and occasionally some of them double over in pain and damn near spit up blood, but nobody stops to help the ones who look like they need to go to the hospital. One woman even

appears annoyed her son can't walk beside her without making choking sounds that would cause a chain smoker from my era to blush.

"Lovely place," I comment dryly.

Harold's old eyes sweep around the room. "Looks like they done got several leaks in their buildings. The smog from outside's seepin' in. I can see damn near half a dozen weak points in the building's structure. Considerin' how tall these buildings are, there must be tons o' stress from all the weight above on these lower levels."

Alpha points across the way. "That looks like an elevator over there. C'mon; I can't wait to get out of here."

"A hovershaft," Marie comments. "How droll. I had those in my base. Here I thought her society would be highly-advanced, but these people are barely holding on. I wonder where the lack of quality is coming from."

Harold answers Marie's question for her. "Marie 12F's data says she don't care about the weak or sick. The smarter, richer people live in the upper levels, and the dumber people who ain't as good as the rest live in the lower levels."

We stop in front of a hovershaft, and Alpha presses a button on the wall, waiting for it to sputter down to our level and step inside. While we pause, a small commotion behind us catches my attention. I glance back and raise an eyebrow at a line of people walking in a straight line and yelling noisily. Their group holds dozens of signs, saying things like '*Down with nutrition bars!*' and '*Demons aren't the enemy, Volgrim are! Stop the perpetual war!*'

A man outside of the protest yells something inaudible, and several people break off from the marching horde, screaming angrily at him and attacking him with fists and signs. "Bootlicker! Down with dual-citizens!!"

Alpha raises an eyebrow but doesn't move to help the man. "Cripes. Maybe the stories of 12F's unified and peaceful universe were a tad overblown."

It's now that I remember the newscast from before. "There are many people furious about the Supreme Commander's recent actions. The news said he was making life miserable for the middle and lower levels."

The hovershaft hums down and its doors open invitingly, allowing us to step inside. As we do and it closes, Marie rubs her nose. "You think so?"

The inertia as the hovershaft lurches into the air nearly makes me lose my lunch, especially when I realize that, once again, they built it out of ninety percent glass. The floor is transparent, making my feet tingle at the thought of falling through and plummeting to my death.

A small screen on the exit begins displaying the same channel broadcast from before. The news anchor from earlier, Kenji, smiles politely. "We continue to deliver updates as we wait for the Supreme Commander, Jason Hiro, to arrive onsite at the recently constructed Planet Hall, where he will deliver what he promises to be the first of several quarterly reports on the State of the Empire. Many people are asking about the Commander's unspoken intentions and whether he has any ulterior motives, but only time will tell. Joining us, we go on-scene with our reporters, and it seems that Caroline has managed to find a fascinating individual to speak to."

The camera changes perspective to show the beautiful blonde woman with the thick lipstick from earlier. Instead of her fellow reporter, now she has a burly-looking man wearing a military uniform standing beside her. He looks uncomfortable like he isn't enjoying being on camera, but every time her eyes meet his, he bows his head and smiles. He probably likes her.

"Thank you, Kenji. I'm here with Admiral Zhao, one of the leading figures at the top of Earthly Affairs. Zhao has worked alongside the Supreme Commander for millennia and crafted many bills even as recently as the last century, when he signed the Demon Enforcement Act. That piece of legislation was responsible for the increased patrols in the Labyrinth and allowed our troops to take down any demons caught outside the Containment Zone. Admiral Zhao, tell me," Caroline leans toward him and gently touches his hand with hers, causing the man to blush madly and pull away. "what do you think the Supreme Commander is going to talk about today?"

Zhao rubs the back of his head and straightens his posture slightly. "Well, ma'am, I'm not at liberty to discuss top-secret governmental affairs, as you know, but if I had to hazard a guess, I imagine he'll spend a large amount of time talking about the free travel between Heaven and Earth. As you know, his actions over the last year have caused some controversy, but our Commander is a wise man, and he understands that demons are our primary foes. His construction of new Energy Conduits to power our military's might has done wonders to help us further choke the demon infestation that threatens our lives."

Caroline nods for a few moments after he finishes, possibly receiving further questions from her station to ask him. "I see. And Admiral, what about the epidemic of suicides wracking our society these past few months? Do you think the Supreme Commander will address those issues?"

Zhao stiffens noticeably. "It is a sad day for our proud Empire when those who contribute nothing take the easy way out, rather than bettering themselves to move to the middle and upper levels of society. Anyone weak enough to cast their life away for a vague promise of nirvana is, in my opinion, a pathetic simpleton. Frankly, I wouldn't blame the Angels and Gods

if they were planning a purge of the new arrivals. Citizens too weak to pledge themselves to our great empire should not be allowed to fill up the living space of our closest friends and allies."

Caroline nods neutrally. "I've heard that you are a staunch supporter of our Empire's creed. What would you say to those who state that it is unfair to the poor, and who claim those at the lower levels have limited upward mobility?"

Admiral Zhao's expression sours. "I have no respect for those who disrespect The Creed. *For glory, we aspire. Perfection, we achieve. Waste, we prevent. Failure, we despise.* Anyone who can't agree with eloquent words like those are likely traitors, and in my opinion, they work for the demons. The worst enemy is the one within."

The reporter slowly shuffles a step away from the admiral, her sweetness from earlier all but gone. "I see. Thank you very much for your time, Admiral Zhao. I'm sure our viewers will find your opinions... enlightening."

"It was my pleasure," The Admiral states, before nodding gruffly and strutting away.

I turn my attention away from the screen only to realize the other three were watching with rapt attention. Alpha rubs his chin. "That guy may be a pragmatist, but his opinions of the less fortunate are a little bit repugnant."

Marie raises an eyebrow. "Are you kidding? He only spoke the truth. If someone is useless, they should work hard to improve themselves or stop wasting limited resources on their worthless life. Nothing he said was controversial in the slightest."

Alpha crosses his arms, frowning. "You've been gifted from birth with extraordinary intelligence, Marie. Some people aren't as lucky as you."

"That's rich," Marie counters. "You've had magical, god-like powers since your 18th birthday. Don't even pretend you care about the unwashed masses. If you did, the Energy Wars wouldn't have happened in the first place."

"Children, children." Harold raises his hands and rests them on Marie and Alpha's shoulders. "Let's not get too heated. Didn't ya hear? The Supreme Commander is going ta' be givin' a speech. Once he appears, we can teleport right to him."

"After the cameras are off, anyway," Alpha retorts. "I see what you mean, though, Harold."

Marie pulls out another cigarette and lights it. I didn't even notice her throw the first one away. "The smog's clearing up outside."

I turn to stare out at the world before us. A sea of metal, concrete, and many space-age materials I can't identify, form the buildings which soar into the sky. Their peaks are so distant

that I can't even make them out. The reflection of the midday sun against sheer walls of glass and polished metal makes me wince.

Marie evaluates the stratoscrapers coolly. "Looks like these towers are nano-assembled. It gives them a denser molecular structure so they can be built far higher than usual and support much more weight. Too bad their design is only good for holding them up; they wouldn't last against a high-energy earthquake or something impacting them. Marie 12F compromised security to get the most height and width possible out of these buildings. Sloppy."

"Seems impressive to me," Alpha counters. "I've never seen a planet like this. Not across all the different universes I've visited."

Marie rolls her eyes. "Perhaps you only find it impressive because you're a simpleton."

Alpha stares at her silently with an expression that says, *maybe you should keep your trap shut*. After a moment, he smiles. "Don't make me drop a boulder on you."

"Funny," she murmurs.

Whatever they're talking about, it appears to be an inside joke. They break out into smiles and chortle before gazing back outside at the view surrounding us.

I rest my hand on the glass wall, wistfully staring at the incredible vista. *I wish Cass and Sam could have been here to see this.*

Yes, murmurs the familiar voice inside me. *You left them behind. I knew you would.*

I ignore the voice. Instead, I sigh. *Alpha still didn't tell me what a Source was. I'll have to ask him later.*

Part 490c: Route C Finale

The four of us sit at a table, bored out of our minds, as the minutes crawl along, slowly turning to hours. The hum of a janitor pushing along a machine to clean the floor mixes with the tranquility of a crowd walking past us, left and right, nobody speaking except in hushed voices.

The people walking around up here dress in what I would describe as 'middle-class attire,' mostly suits, uniforms, things of that sort. Occasionally a lightly armored security officer will pass the four of us, not bothering to care about our existence in the slightest. The more I think about it, the more I realize Alpha must have silently thoughtsmithed magic to make other people take less notice of us. He's made us blend in with the background somewhat. We aren't invisible, but we might as well be.

Unlike the windows on the lower levels, the middle section has a great view. The smog is almost a mile below us, and while we can see traces of it in the distance, a skyline of steel structures rising into the atmosphere makes for a humbling spectacle. Never in my life did I picture myself sitting in a cafeteria with a view like this.

A voice speaks up from the room's loudspeakers.

"Good morning to all members of Humanity. As per the promise I made last year, I am giving this speech today as part of my bi-monthly update regarding the operations of our vast empire."

Alpha and Marie raise their heads up simultaneously to glance across the room at the viewscreen. The man onscreen is the same as Alpha and me, a Jason. Apparently, he's the one known as Jason X. He's our target.

I follow their gaze and examine him. He's wearing a military uniform, neatly pressed, yet he hasn't tucked his collar in properly. It's as if he was in a rush when he left his house and forgot to maintain his appearance. The fact nobody running the video program thought to fix his clothes tells me they probably didn't have time.

Jason X keeps his disarming smile as he continues to speak, though I've already missed a bit of what he said. "If humans kill themselves any more than they already have, the amount of energy flowing to the angels will slow dramatically. In the worst case scenario, it could invert, causing the angels to lose more energy than we can give."

His demeanor is that of a composed leader, one doing his best to look out for the interests of his people. Or is it? It might be a facade. He's probably Hope, after all. Hope is a sociopath

without a single decent bone in his body: a merciless killer.

Marie yawns. "Gods. This speech is the worst."

"You said it," Alpha mutters. "He's so monotone that I'm about to fall asleep."

"All I am asking is that people realize the folly of their actions," Jason X continues, but I don't get to hear what he says next. The person we were waiting for arrives.

"Marie Becker?" A young man strolls up to us, but he seems hesitant. "Goodness, it's been a while! We haven't seen you in the Engineering Corps for months!"

Silver, that's his name. At least, that's what Harold told us when Central Hub sent the pertinent personnel files. Apparently, Silver is a high-ranking person in this stream. He looks to be around twenty-four years old, but his youthful body is a mirage, like everyone else around here. Harold has explained several fascinating things about this universe, including the fact that humans have perfected nanobot technology to the point where it even gives them immortality. I can't trust my eyes when it comes to judging people's supposed ages.

Marie stands up, relieved she doesn't have to lounge around anymore. "Took you long enough. I brought guests from the- err, the Outer Rim! We've been waiting for an escort for over an hour!"

Marie told us earlier that she doesn't know anyone in this stream, but her bossy personality and quick-thinking is terrific at times like these. The young guy shrinks back, unnerved by her annoyance. "S-sorry, ma'am. I've been keeping an eye on the target, as you ordered. I wasn't expecting you back today, of all days, so I was at the-"

"Excuses!" Marie barks a single word, silencing the poor guy. "I don't pay you to lounge around! Now hurry up and get us moving! I lost my access credentials, so you'll be showing my good friends the sights, understand?!"

Silver winces, but confusion appears on his face. "Pay me...?"

Marie's outrage falters for a moment. I can almost see the gears turn in her head as she thinks to herself, *shit, Harold already said there wasn't any form of currency in this universe*. She instantly resumes her previous anger and dials it up to eleven. "You know damn well what I meant! Hurry up! I want to show them our prestigious Engineering section!"

Silver nods quickly and beckons to us, but doesn't take his eyes off Marie. "Uh, come along, then."

Harold rubs his knee as the three of us stand. Jason X is still blabbing about stuff like he was before, and I'm in no mood to listen, so we head off after Silver.

A minute later, I nudge Marie and whisper, "How did you do that?"

"Do what?"

I gesture at Silver's back. He doesn't see me since he and Harold are discussing something up ahead of the group. "You took command and put him in his place. He has no doubt you're the same as Marie 12F. You must have mimicked her personality to the T."

She shrugs. "One thing you'll learn if you hang around people from the Central Hub is that Maries very rarely have any significant personality divergences from one another. I just treated him the way any Marie would, and things worked out perfectly." She pulls her hair back and lets it slide down her right shoulder. "As they always do."

"I see."

Silently, I ponder her response for a few moments while listening to Silver excitedly babble to Harold about the newest developments in robotics. I've yet to meet a Marie who wasn't arrogant, condescending, and more than a little stuck-up, and now she tells me they're all like that. No matter how smart they are, it doesn't fill me with glee to have an army of sociopaths 'protecting' the multiverse and its existence.

I wonder what each Marie gets out of it.

Sighing, I bug her again. "Why do you want to see the Engineering Corps?"

Marie answers instantly. "Marie 12F was a Source Marie, like me. She and I have similar voracious appetites for science. I can only hope she's developed unique technology that I haven't. The problem with Maries in the Central Hub is that they're always busy keeping track of the Multiverse. They lack time to expand their minds and unwind by dabbling with theoretical physics."

I rub a speck from my eye. "What, you think she'll have some crazy military technology?"

A shrug. "Possibly. It's not always about war and killing though, Jason. There are entire fields of science you probably know nothing about. I'm an expert in all of them."

"Every single one?"

"Yes."

The smug look on her face tells me not to test her. She's lived for tens of millions of years, so it's believable that she's as brilliant as she claims. She's smarter than me, at least.

My eyes narrow as I stare at Alpha's back. *Dunno what his excuse is, though. Alpha's stupid, despite being older than her by a wide margin.*

"What are you staring at?" Marie glares at me from the corner of her eye. "Wipe that smile off your face."

I was smiling? I quickly rub my lips. "Sorry, I was just thinking about Alpha. Isn't he much, much older than you? He claimed to be a billion years old, but he doesn't seem like the sharpest knife in the drawer."

Her irritation vanishes in an instant. "Hah, you're right about that! He's a dullard. Always was, even when I worked for the Central Hub. Jason Alpha is the muscle they send in when things need a quick cleanup. He's a nice enough fellow, but he's screwed up so many times that nobody trusts him with any responsibilities involving brain-power. The thing is, you don't become infinitely smarter as you age. Some people are born smarter than others, and everyone has a plateau. It just so happens that the average Jason is lower than the average human, who is far lower than the average Marie. Understand?"

Her words have a biting edge to them. "You don't think an intelligent Jason can exist? Or that a stupid Marie can?"

She shakes her head. "While it may technically be possible, all universes branch off from existing ones. Most of them branch off from points when Maries and Jasons are already born, meaning our potential is already determined. The universes that branch off before our births will often prevent our existences entirely, meaning a stupid or smart variant won't appear. It's simply not how the multiverse works."

Today, I've learned something interesting. "The multiverse isn't infinite, then?"

Marie sighs. "The primitive notion of a universe for every choice and action was debunked, quite literally, tens of millions of years ago. Such a thing does not exist in reality."

Our group slows to a crawl as Silver stops at an intimidating doorway. Its metallic surface has several crisscrossing lines, indicating it's a double-sided door that slides into itself and opens from the middle. At twenty-feet tall and thirty feet wide, it's more than big enough for a few side-by-side cars to glide through without hitting the edges.

He swipes a keycard reader, and it turns green, causing the giant door to slide open silently. Silver's eyes light up as he strolls through the doorway, spinning on his heel to walk backward. He smiles at Marie. "We've kept up the usual projects, miss Becker! Isotope 823 is stable, as it was when you left! Oh, and the upgrades to the trifornium purifiers have progressed another four percent!"

Marie stretches her lips to smile faintly. "That's nice. I'd like to show our guests the full catalog of our upcoming projects. Could you grab the registry for me?"

Silver rubs his hands together, but though his smile is still present, a flash of nervousness appears. "Err, the full catalog, ma'am? Even the black-level projects?"

"Did I stutter?"

He shakes his head. "No, of course not. I'll be right back."

Silver skitters away, leaving us alone to examine the room. I expected to see dozens of men and women shambling about in lab coats, security officers and such, perhaps even a bureaucrat or two, but the place is nearly empty. A couple of janitors, two armed security guards standing with their backs against opposite walls, and a few scientists chattering among each other on the opposite side of the room are all I can spot.

Meanwhile, sci-fi looking shelves hang down from the ceiling, countertops covered in gadgets and devices litter the floor, and a few tiny drones buzz around holding tubes filled with colored liquid, transporting them from machines to their counterparts. It's a giant science lab, likely for developing weaponry and all kinds of other crazy shit, but there's nobody here!

I cough into my fist. "Err, where is everyone?"

Marie shuffles over to a table and picks up a device to examine it. "Don't know. Don't care."

Harold and Alpha exchange glances before the old man taps the side of his head. "That Jason X guy is givin' his speech, remember? I bet they're off watching it. Seemed important ta' me."

Alpha nods. "Makes sense. Security is a little light for a place like this, though."

"No, no, not at all!" Silver appears out of nowhere, a worried smile on his face. He wrings his hands together nervously, always flicking his gaze at Marie's back as she leans over the table. "To make it to the Engineering Corps, a spy or saboteur would need to bypass several dozen layers of security. You passed them on the way here, but my security card disabled the- oh!" Silver cuts off abruptly and slides over to Marie. She's holding something in her hand and carefully examining it. "I'm very sorry, Miss Becker, but that prototype isn't complete yet. We're running a few weeks behind schedule."

"Mmm." Marie places it back on the table. "I've been on vacation for too long. Remind me what it does, again?"

I can hear the relief in Silver's voice that she isn't yelling at him for another failure. "I-it's the handheld reconnaissance drone, remember? It's small enough to bypass level three Volgrim shielding without triggering a detection blip."

Marie nods and waves her hand flippantly. "Ah, yes, that thing. Do be sure to speed up the program, then. Do you have the project registry for me?"

After blanking out for a moment, Silver nods. "Oh, right! I've got it right here for you, Miss Becker." He hands her a tablet but stands in front of it to block our view. I can hear him whisper

something to her about *not showing black-level projects to outsiders and the trouble it could cause*, but she waves him off.

"You don't need to tell me, Silver. I really just need to check the status of a few projects."

While she and Silver calmly debate the merits of sharing information with outsiders, Alpha gently reaches over and tugs at my sleeve. Suddenly, in my mind, I hear his voice.

Don't trust Marie 19A. I don't know why she wants 12F's files, but little good can come of it.

A twinge of nerves comes over me. I start to speak up, then realize Alpha is probably reading my mind right now. *Creepy*. Oops, hope he didn't hear that!

Why don't you stop her, then?

Alpha frowns. She continues chatting with Silver, but her eyes flick over to us. *She's a Marie.*

The hell does that have to do with anything?

Alpha almost imperceptibly shakes his head. *You have yet to learn, Sparky. Never underestimate a Marie. One slight, one aggravation, and they never forget. If I don't kill her, then telling her 'no' is asking for a lot of trouble. Even if I did kill her, 19A, of all the Maries, is likely to have a backup plan. Maybe a clone, or something.*

Yeah? Why do you say that?

Darkness covers his face. *Because I killed Marie 12B, the one who Marie 19A was assigned to replace. When 19A first emerged, I thought she was a ghost. I didn't yet know about the existence of the Central Hub. It scared me. She wasn't a clone, but that doesn't mean she couldn't make one.*

What, you're afraid of her?

Alpha's lip twitches. *Hard to say, Sparky. There are forces in this universe that a billion years have taught me nothing about. The most unknowable is that of the female mind, especially when it belongs to a Marie. After all, I can't read her thoughts. Even if I could...*

You can't read her mind?

Not even with Thoughtsmithing. I thought it was a localized anti-energy field, but now I don't know.

Marie turns to us and holds the pad up so we can't see, but reads off the entries out loud. "Investigations into producing auditory hallucinations, mesmeric feedback loops, a project to establish a bio-engineering base on a localized planetary cluster 12,000 lightyears away, bio-engineering and crossbreeding of human and demon DNA, hardening the human carapace to

withstand greater gravity pressures so we can colonize planets with masses greater than four EM... interesting."

"What's 'EM?'" I ask.

"Earth Masses. The larger a planet, the stronger its gravity. After a certain point, you'll feel as though there's an anvil strapped to every inch of your body, and eventually, a massive planet's gravity will crush you into pulp."

"Pleasant," I mutter dryly.

A movement behind Marie catches my eye. One of the security guards raises his hand to his ear. After a moment, he stiffens in alarm. He drops his hand and beelines for us. "Marie Becker! Emergency! The Supreme Commander, he's been-!"

The words have hardly left his mouth when suddenly the building shakes. Everyone yelps in alarm, and all of us get tossed to the right like ragdolls. My body kicks into high gear and I right myself in an instant, landing on my palm and pirouetting to my feet, even as more tremors rock the building. A sound like a battering ram smashing into concrete blasts from every wall, and the grinding of metal on metal makes me jerk my head up in alarm.

Alpha, too, catches himself, and before Marie can hit the ground, a cushion of air catches her and returns her to her feet. Judging by the look on her face, she wasn't responsible for the save. Alpha must have thoughtsmithed and caught her.

Harold doesn't even flinch from all the commotion, and his gyroscopic sensors allow him to keep himself upright without any trouble, but poor Silver isn't as lucky. He yelps in surprise and smacks against a cabinet, nearly falling unconscious as his body hits the floor. The scientists and guards yell in alarm, as beakers and tools fly from their holding positions and clatter to the ground.

"What the fuck?!" The expletive blasts from Marie's mouth, unbidden by common courtesy in the heat of the moment. "Guard! Status report! Now!"

Above us, a robotic male voice speaks from the ceiling. "All guards in the Engineering Corps have been rendered unconscious. Sending emergency distress call to the Medical Division for retrieval and regeneration. Error. The Medical Division is unable to respond."

"Unable to respond?" Alpha echoes the voice above. "Uh, computer! What's going on? Give us a status report!"

Silence. The computer doesn't reply. The building shakes once again, and an explosion *booms* in the distance.

Harold wheezes. "Son, his name is Samuel. You gotta chat him up nicely or he won't talk back!"

Marie rolls her eyes. "Samuel! Give me a status report!"

The male voice keeps its artificial calmness. "Request received. Request denied. You are not an authorized representative."

"What do you mean? I'm Marie Becker! I run this corps!"

I can practically hear the computer shake his head at her. "That statement is false. You are not Marie Becker. Please contact an authorized representative to place requests, or feel free to contact support at any time of day by calling-"

"Gahhhh!" Marie bellows in anger and kicks the wall. "Stupid hunk of junk! Alpha, we need to make heads or tails of what's going on!"

Another explosion sounds off, but this one is much closer than the others. A shockwave rushes down the hallway as several windows implode hundreds of feet outside the Engineering Corps.

Alpha takes a defensive stance. "Intruders. Armored. Volgrim, I think."

"Volgrim?! You've gotta be kidding me!" I take a defensive stance as well, just as several canisters come flying down the hall, smoke pouring from them and clouding the vision. My eyes start to water, and my knees lock up, before I realize they must be tear gas, or something worse. A feeling of paralysis starts to take me, but I cough out a word. " **Immune!** "

A second later, I'm back to full. " **Ventilate.** " The smoke vanishes into nothingness as ten armored people come charging at us, though they noticeably falter when they realize the smoke is gone. Pausing, they hop behind cover and begin blasting shots of plasma at us, but Alpha doesn't flinch. The white-hot energy blasts ricochet off an invisible shield.

Alpha's face contorts several times. "What?! These aren't Volgrim. They're demons. Why are demons using conventional weaponry and armor?"

Again, he must have thoughtsmithed inside of their minds or something. Marie may be correct about his idiocy, but when it comes to fighting, he never breaks a sweat. I glance back at her. "Alpha, they must be trying to secure the contents of the Engineering Corps. I don't know what's in there, but we can't let them-"

"We can," he mutters. "You don't understand, Sparky. This is a Source universe. We can't meddle in its affairs. We're just here to investigate. We need to pull out and let the local forces take care of things."

The sound of a scientist moaning behind me makes the hairs on the back of my neck stand on end. "If these are demons, they'll kill the scientists! We can't leave them to die!"

"We can, and we will," Marie says, as she appears beside me. Her voice has a note of caution in it. "I may not be in the Central Hub anymore, but even I know what can happen when we meddle in streams we shouldn't. Alpha, get us out of here."

Alpha nods. "Too bad for the kid."

The room shifts, and suddenly the enemy combatants vanish. We arrive in the midst of fire and brimstone, as windows explode and people scream in terror. We're back in the waiting room from before Silver found us, and everything is different. All the windows have been blown out, and the stratoscrapers in the distance scream in pain as blasts of energy rain down from the sky to pummel their metal and glass into atoms.

A horrible rumbling shakes the ground, as though every inch of the floor were being drilled with a jackhammer. Miles away, a stratoscraper tumbles down, pulverizing the floors below it as it collapses, only to stop midway and tumble to the side, pounding into its closest neighbor, tearing it down.

Harold appears beside Alpha. "Son of a dadgum biscuit! I patched into th' telly news, and they jes' said Jason X went on a flippin' rampage! Lookit the video!"

His eye shifts, and a holographic projection plays out, suspended in midair.

Jason X sweeps his arms toward the crowd. "Even if the angels and gods were to one day become our allies, I cannot stress this enough-!"

He doesn't get to finish his sentence. Something unseen pounds him in the head, sending his body careening to the right, and leaving him lying on the ground, dead.

A crowd of agents leaps into action, blocking his body. They scream and bark orders in confusion, but I manage to pick out something about him being shot. An assassination attempt?

"Harold, I thought you said he went on a rampage! Someone murdered him! Jesus Christ!"

Harold holds his hand up to silence me. "Keep watching, boy!"

And so I do. Alpha, Marie, Harold, and I all watch silently as one of the men guarding the Supreme Commander explodes into a puddle of blood and gore. It's like a grenade went off in his body, turning him from human to wallpaper in a single second. A few moments pass, and the rest of the guards explode in kind, until eventually Jason X raises up from the ground, tongue lolling out of his mouth. His arms and legs dangle uselessly at his sides, so he must be using telekinesis to move.

A woman comes flying into view, apparently yanked by Jason X's telekinesis. "Oh my god, you're a-" She's cut off before she can finish by Jason X tearing her leg from her body and beating her to death with it. The crowd shrieks in horror but one man dares to stand up to X. I recognize him from the earlier broadcast; he's the Chinese-looking guy, Admiral Zhao.

"Monster! Demon! What the hell are you?!" The admiral courageously stands up to the monster facing him and unloads his gun on X, but it's useless. A few moments later, Jason X speaks a single word, " **Inferno!** "

I turn away, unable to watch, as the camera seems to gleefully pan over the horrid image of people screaming their last words. A massive gout of flame surges over them, tearing flesh from bone.

Harold shuts the hologram off. Alpha covers his mouth. He looks like he's about to retch. "Son of a bitch... he's Hope. He has to be Hope."

"That was monstrous," Marie says. She tries to keep calm, but her lip twitches. Even the invulnerable Marie, usually immune to emotion, is horribly disturbed. "What did we just witness? That was carnage unlike anything I've ever seen."

Alpha gnashes his teeth. "That's *Hope*, without a doubt. It's been an eternity, but I can never forget the look of glee on his face. He took something from me, something precious, and savored the experience. He delights in pain and torture. I have to stop him."

Memories bubble up in my mind. Cassiel and Samantha scream in pain before their necks snap. Hope's face- *my face*, smiles back at me.

" We have to stop him, Alpha. Don't you dare count me out."

"Right." Alpha nods. "Found him. Let's go."

* * *

An instant later, there he is. We disappear and reappear in the middle of a broken lobby. Several demons lie unmoving on the ground, as the Jason across from us smiles and licks his lips. After a moment, he stumbles back, apparently noticing our presence.

Something's wrong with his eyes. While his arms and legs flop uselessly at his sides, his eyes move about aimlessly, and they are visibly clouded over with grey mist. He's... blind?

"There you are. We've come to stop you, once and for all, *Hope*," Alpha says. He takes a single step toward Hope, and the other Jason panics. Fear stretches over his face.

" **Create!** " Hope barks out a word, and a pebble appears in midair. I stare at it in confusion for a split second, wondering to myself, *why the fuck is he creating a pebble?!*

Then he yells again. " **FIRE!!** "

The pebble disappears. A light like the surface of the sun fills the room, and a thunderstorm hits my body, as well as the rest of us. Before I get blown off my feet, it vanishes and sucks away, perhaps to another universe. Blinking, I spot Alpha, hand outstretched, the pebble clutched firmly in his grasp.

"That won't work." Alpha releases the pebble, and it falls, smashing into the ground with unusual force. It must have been ultra-dense or made of hefty materials. "I knew you were a monster. But this? Now you've gone too far, Hope. You can't even pick an ally. You just devour the demons and the humans alike for your own selfish greed."

Hope smiles, but it's a fake expression. He's nervous. He's scared. "My name is Jason Hiro. I can't see you, but your voice is the same as mine. I suppose you're another one of Marie's clones, eh?"

Alpha narrows his gaze. "You must be lying. Of course, you're Hope. Who do you think you're fooling? Your actions speak louder than words."

Why is Hope denying his existence? He knows who he is. He knows we've come to stop him. Why play dumb?

He must be Hope. He has to be!

But then, maybe something else is going on...

"Hold on; maybe he isn't lying. Perhaps he doesn't remember yet." I prod Alpha, giving him pause before he leaps forward and tears Hope's head off.

Perhaps he doesn't remember the past. He was hit by a bullet in the head. Just look at him!

I send a single thought to Alpha, and to my surprise, he nods. His voice plays in my mind. *Good point. If he isn't Hope, then that means the real threat is still out there. I should confirm his identity.*

Alpha takes two steps toward Hope. "You have a point. Let us see if he is lying, then. **Remember.** "

Seconds pass, Hope stumbles forward to the floor as his limbs twitch violently. He can't keep himself flying with telekinesis. Mental strain, perhaps? His mouth opens and closes, as though he wants to scream, but can't.

Seconds pass, and finally, Hope shakes the pain off and lifts himself up once more.

He speaks one sentence.

"I'm not Hope, but I know who is."

* * *

The building shakes and trembles. Suddenly, the whole thing careens to the left, making me feel like a massive spaceship planted into its side. Everyone is nearly thrown off their feet, but just like before, we regain our footing.

Jason X, apparently not named Hope, smiles wildly at us. "Long time, no see, Heroes!"

Harold jumps in alarm and pulls up his temporal-communicator wrist-watch, then his eyes bulge. What in tarnation?! 23,000 temporal messages? From Helen?!"

Between Jason X and our group, a flash of movement activates my reflexes. I duck down and aim my hand at one- no, two figures who have just appeared.

A giant orc whose head nearly scrapes the ceiling stands beside a young blonde woman, her face echoing a recent memory in my mind. She's wearing what I can only describe as a Hypersuit. It takes me a moment, but I manage to remember her face. *She's the girl who ran away in Hero City! I chased after her!* But- but what the hell is she doing here?!

The girl takes two steps forward and stabs a finger into Alpha's chest. "I knew it! You caused the convergence! Idiot!"

All the while, Harold stares at his temporal communicator in stunned silence. "Helen? H-Helen?!"